Princess of Nothingness

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Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Categories:
F/F, F/M

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Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Kyle/Lonnie/Rogelio (She-Ra), Nyarlathotep & Yog-Sothoth (Cthulhu Mythos), Asindesa/Shadow weaver

Characters:
Nyarlathotep (Cthulhu Mythos), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Mi-Go (Cthulhu Mythos), Wrong Hordak (She-Ra), Eti (OC), Asindesa di Vir (OC), Rosie Pearl (OC), Lord Admiral Antares (OC), Lady Cala Grayskull/Calamity(OC), Dilayla (OC)

Additional Tags:
Space Opera, Action/Adventure, Pulp, Crossover, Ancient Evil, Old Lies, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner Lives (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner Redemption (She-Ra), Post-Canon, Catra finds a family, Queen Angela Lives, Space Pirates

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by Arturius22

Summary

Everything happens five years after the end of the series, when different forces are moving towards Etheria. A grim sorceress with a scarred face, along with her ward Cala Grayskull, winged Pirate Captain Moonshadow, a feline girl named Eti and Lord Admiral Antares with his Armada.

Prolog: Awakening into the Nightmare

Chapter Notes

> This is the first chapter of my fan fic. I decided that Nyarlathotep should refer to itself in the plural. Please leave your comments and opinions.

She woke up.

She started coughing. There was an oily liquid in her lungs. A foul taste filled her mouth, like a mixture of blood, pus and sweat. She squatted on her lap and vomited bile. Then she looked around

She regretted it immediately.

All around was an undulating plain, shrouded in a foul-smelling yellow mist. The ground was like the rubbery mantle of some mollusk, covered with numerous pools of black liquid she had just gulped out. There weren't plants, just clumps of something, they looked like ulcers. The air was musty, smelled of sweetly rotting flesh. Four-legged skinny creatures scrambled along the surface of this place, driving long probes into the "ground", like mosquitoes into a human body.

"Orocorans are parasites that feed on the sap of this planet ... A bit like you our dear Shadow Weaver ... though they are never so greedy."

She turned to see a tall man dressed in a tight-fitting black outfit enveleped by black smoke. He had a golden mark on his chest, resembling an inverted aankh. He had a handsome, thin face. His eyes shone with a golden glow and his head was burning. He bowed mockingly.

" This face is Carsai The King, Keeper of the Divine Planet Aucturn, whose infinite beauty you can watch."

She looked at the place, that surrounded her. The same space she had seen before stretched out everywhere. The only diversion were the hills stretching in the distance, disturbingly resembling vertebrae protruding from a skeleton half buried in the ground.

" You have to get used to being able to enjoy its charm, but we didn't invite you here to admire the views"

She pursed her lips. For most of her life, she wore a veil and then a mask. Now, with her face exposed, she felt uncomfortable.

"I should be dead…" - She said hoarsely.

"You were dead, our dear Shadow Weaver. You were as dead as mortal can be, but that does not absolve you from paying your debt." - said Carsai and they came up to the woman.

She swallowed loudly. She felt sick from the bittersweet aftertaste. She knew in her heart that power always had a price, but she had never imagined she would pay it so literally.

"But sacrifice ..." she said in defensive tone.

"Your sacrifice has been recognized, and that's why we talk so politely. Otherwise… This discussion would be absolutely one-sided." his eyes lit up with a glow so bright that he was blinding - And I remind you that you tried to kill us ... Or at least this face.

"It was not my intention ..."

They ordered with a gesture that she should be silent.

"By accident, then, you allowed, or even helped, to activate the weapon of the First Ones, which was aimed at their enemies, including that face ... Perhaps it was an accident, or perhaps you wanted to free yourself from our contract. " said Carsai.

" I haven't made a deal with you, I've never heard of you. " she said resigned. She did not know who this creature was. It didn't

matter, though. She was so incredibly tired, she doubted anything could agitate her.

" You know us. Carsai The King is one of thousands of masks that share one name ... Nyarlathotep. " They smiled and Shado Weaver shuddered. She now fully understood what a terrible situation she was in.

" But, we are not mortals. We are stranger to such feelings as pride, lust for power, envy. We also do not hold a grudge, especially since you got rid of a few problems that have plagued the galaxy from many millennia, and for that we are grateful. However… It doesn't mean we'll forgive you your debt. You see, you may prove to be of use to us. After all, the universe abhors a vacuum ... " they laughed - Sorry for the bad joke, we have more important things to discuss. - they said and approached the sorceress. They knelt down.

" You should be pleased that your ward survived, safe and sound. Or maybe you will be sad about this? You've never been a too loving mother… " They smiled and their eyes glittered.

" I just wanted ... That she would complete her destiny, that she could be what she should become and ... I think I did my job well ... No matter what I did. I made her who she is. I can answer for that. I know I hurt her ... both of them and so many others. So if you're going to punish me for something, punish me for it. " she said and looked fiercely into the eyes of the Outer God.

" You have a lot of old strength left in you. That's good. We do not judge you because your morality is alien to us. We are as old as time itself, and we don't see the world in your way. The suffering you caused ... The pain you inflicted... is meaningless in the face of the infinite vastness of the indifferent universe ... " they said, and in his eyes she saw the light of stars so old that they were dead when Etheria arose " Likewise your sacrifice, but not yours debt. However, we are infinitely gracious, and instead of suffering unimaginable, we will give you the opportunity to return."

She looked up at the creature that barely look like a human. She knew suffering, it had filled every moment of her existence for so long. She-Ra treatment, or honestly saying Adora, helped a bit, but it was only a slight relief. But now it was different. She could breathe freely. Despite the scars, hers face no longer burned with the cold flame. She was able to move like a young woman, more agile before Micah failed her. But such a gift always came at a price. And she was afraid she knew what she was like

"If you want me to betray ... that I deny the choice of which ..." he will interrupt her, raising his hand.

" Betrayal ... It's such an ambiguous word. Can be betrayer someone who has served only himself for almost all his life? You've always wanted power, but when you knew you weren't strong enough to get it, you were using others. They were extensions of you, your ... Shadows that you could send to obey your will ... Only one time, when you did not act selfishly and now you are at our mercy ... But we only want the universe to become a safe place for mortals again, we love so much in all our masks. " Carsai smiled, and that smile could burn souls - We want to make sure that in the future no one wants to release such power ..."

She shook her head vigorously.

" Nobody will use the Hearth again, you said yourself that it was destroyed ... The First ones are dead, so no one can rebulid it anymore!"

Carsai looked at her silently. She felt that she wasn't noticed something, Something extremely important.

"That is not dead which can eternal lie and with strange aeons even death may die. You know that at least one of them is alive, but it can't be the only one ... They are hiding somewhere far away, in a place unknown even to us. So it is imperative that this place be found. " they said and stared into the distance expectantly. Shadow Weaver felt relieved. She won't have to go back to it all. It always seemed to her that everything she did was

for a greater purpose. But it always came at a high price, and she wasn't sure she wished others would have to pay it again.

" However, in order to find the Firsts ones, you must return to Etheria. Not alone, of course. Some preparations were made long time ago with such a moment in mind. You have to understand something. We are an emissary of the Outer Gods. Their Soul. And we are always happy to help each other... There is The Key and The Gate. The Key and the Gate! Do you understand? We have prepared a special gift for the inhabitants of Etheria, but you must hurry, my dear, because those who want to regain their inheritance have already began to plot ... We are not alone in the darkness between the stars. They have many plans ... Many servants ... And some of them are Everhungry. But our gift should… make us able to take the lead. It is a very beautiful gift. You'll love it."

First she smelled the smel…. The smell was strange, a bit repulsive and unnatural, like it should'nt never be on earth. Then she felt a Presence… An alien presence even for this place… Then she heard the words.

" Hey Mother… We have many wonderful adventures ahead." [/i]

A few years later. Fringe of the Pact Worlds.

The research vessel of the Kemanis University – Wisdom of Triune had travelingtraveled the vast expanses of the fringes of the system collecting samples for research. Businessmen from Absalon, especially from Abadar Corp, often commissioned remote areas to be explored so that raw materials could be harvested here. Of course, the main task was to study the history of the development of the system and such things, but Captain Ricat, Ysoki of Absalon Station, was well aware that finding economically valuable places was an important source of income for the University. The work was boring and tiring, but not too difficult and also well paid. So he didn't have much to complain about, even in the case of a pirate attack, the University would buy him out.

But now something has interrupted this boring journey across the endless void. Signal detected. Weak, barely detectable at this distance, would most certainly be overlooked by someone less meticulous or… less bored. A small object in the middle of the void could drift here alone for countless eons, but it was found by a Ricat who would not have missed such an opportunity. If only because of Ysoki's healthy curiosity. He ordered the ship to be directed at the object, and when they were within range, he launched a scan. It turned out to be a rescue capsule of unknown origin. More importantly, there was life in the capsule. Well, even if he wanted to, he couldn't back down. By law, he now had to take the survivor aboard, help him, and drive him to the nearest place where he could find a safe haven, which Ricat didn't mind much, because the capsule itself seemed valuable enough to go to the trouble of himself. So he ordered the grippers to be fired and the object pulled in. Then he and Ikt, Shiren technician, went to the cargohold. There they looked at the capsule. It was ancient, with an indeterminate origin. There was a symbol of a white rose on the lid ...

Part one: Once upon a time in Saltmarsh - Awakening into the Life

She woke up. In many ways. She could smell her own unwashed body, dirty hair, sweaty sheets, and Toshi's fur. The electric blue foxiy was asleep against her back, snoring loudly, but as soon as she got up it flew up and started rubbing against her back. An electric shiver ran through her entire body.
"The rainy days are gone foxi ... It will be alright ... " she said, although she knew that rainy days would come back. They always came back.
How much time has passed She wasn't sure. It had started to improve before the last dinner, and now she had slept all „night". It was hard to keep track of time on the ship. She counted the meals and medications Bina and Itel brought her, but she always lost track. She didn't even remember what she had been fed lately, but she didn't eat much because she fel hungry. Very hungry. But first she had to take care of more important matters. She examined the old gun, made sure it was clean. Then she did the same with the sniper rifle. She cleaned the scope and checked that the laser sight was charged. Then she looked at her right shoulder. It looked like it was made of brass, but it wasn't smooth, but was porous. It was covered with numerous, barely visible runes. No one could read them, though Dr. Sidonius had made some hypotheses, but she preferred Old Leech not to look at her too much, because she always wanted to stab him in a dead brain. What is certain is that it is not an ordinary prosthesis, but an ancient Archeotech. She took the energy battery from the cabinet and held it in an artificial hand. She felt a tingle to the elbow where it becoming into living flesh. The runes, at least the ones on the palm of her hand, glowed blue-golden. No one else saw them, but she liked to watch them. The limb was lighter now, and it was better able to conduct sensation. She fed Toshi some energy, but not too much as he was getting hyperactive. She looked around her cabin. It was cramped, with only a bed, a cupboard and a sink, and a cramped toilet. Exactly. She went to take care of herself, then washed herself in a bowl of water. The

water regime in space was a serious matter which she did not want to neglect. Then she got dressed and reluctantly made the bed. She didn't like cleaning, but she hadn't been helping the rest of the crew for the past few days, so that's what she should be doing without whining. Then she went to the mirror. The room was dim, but it didn't bother her, she could see in almost total darkness. She stood in front of the sheet metal mirror. She combed her straight, greasy dark red hair. Her head was shaved on the left side, so that the rest of her hair fell to the right. Her skin was caramel and her mouth was thin. The eyes were yellow, catlike, but with many blue spots that grew when she felt ... when she felt. And she usually felt when she wanted to hurt someone, and she was pretty good at i. My left hand was stripped of her fingernails by surgery a long time ago… as punishment. So she tied the retractable blade to her wrist. Finally, she buckled on a belt with grenades. She felt confident. She saw the death zone forming around her. Anyone in it will suffer. Nobody can touch her. Pleasant warmth spread over her body. She purred

Breakfast on the edge of the abyss.

Bina oversaw Lilka, Alatar and Itel preparing breakfast. Admittedly, it was hardly to name a preparation, since it was all about reheating packages of soy noodles with sauce, yeast paste, and mushroom stew, but having breakfast together was a ritual they rarely abandoned. Ireanis sat at the table, looking around with a slightly thoughtful smile. The silver-haired, dark-skinned elf in the somewhat old-fashioned sorceress' outfit was their mage, and a very powerful mage at that… as long as she was sober. Keeping her in this state required a lot of attention and patience, which they often could not afford ... She was someone unique, a sorceress from ancient Golarion, who ... well, cast a spell once while drunk. She studied somewhere in a place called Mwangi and acquired great knowledge there, but soon something terrible happened and ... she started drinking. She never talked about it, although she was eager to talk about her adventures, and her charges liked to listen to these stories, even if they were half made up. Besides, she was their only quasi teacher they had, and even despite her peculiarity and periodic drinking, she was able to conjure up something. Sometimes…
The boom camera zoomed in and came the metallic voice of the communicator.

" Hello and wish bon apetit to you!" said Ilemshaw

"And we also wish you to bon apetit fishy!" said Lilka, who was spreading a flat bread with yeast paste.

Ilemshaw ... Ancient being of the Algholite race that they rescued from Kesler ... Or who helped save them. Now he stayed in a large aquarium in a special room and was their science officer. There were several cameras and multiple booms all over the ship, so he could do his job without leaving the tank, and they had a few small drones that he could control. The problem was that,

according to the ancient legends, Algholitu were the dark beings behind many terrible events… But to them Ilemshaw was kind…. And she could only hope he wouldn't turn against them ...

They heard footsteps and Eti entered in her everyday clothes, that is, as if she was going to war. She stood in the doorway, yawned, and, walking slowly, sat down in the chair without looking at anyone. Bina felt the pressure slowly escape from all of them. This time Eti had "rainy days" for quite a long time, as they euphemistically described it, so everyone was already waiting for her to come back… Itel gave a bowl of mushroom stew. Eti sniffed the dish and made a face of disgust.

"There is no meat? Where is the meat?" she asked with a gloomy voice looking at everyone sullenly

"Nice to see you too, Eti. The meat came out a week ago." Bina said sarcastically, but everyone knew that when she complained and whined, she was fine.

"Why don't we eat Alatar? His would last for a few weeks… Even including down the iron-things!" Eti said and pointed the finger of her gloved hand at Alatar.

Well, admittedly, as a dragonkin he was the largest of all the young crew members and perhaps the largest of all. Especially since he was slightly overweight. Though compared to the true dragon he was a tiny. He looked like a humanoid dragon with a silvery scale. He also had quite a few implants, however, including a wrist interface and a tail welder. His grandmother was a wealthy entrepreneur on the absalon and helped them get some of the funds for this trip, but also financed his education as a Technomancer.

"Very funny. Why shouldn't we eat you?" The technomancer asked, but the girl answer him in her calm, slightly dull voice
"I am a predator, and predators are usually not eaten." she turned her head to the side, without blinking, watching at dragonkin.
"I am a dragon, and dragons are at the top of the food chain!" said indignant Alatar.
Eti tilted her head back.
"Dragons maybe. I haven't tried fight with any of them yet, but you are a dragon whelp, my dear, and quite fat" she said in the same gentle tone.
"Eti won!" cried Lilka joyfully, a short red-haired girl with face and shoulders covered with Orc tattoos, or at least pictures that should look like them… it was quite… a touchy issue. She was a year or two younger than the others, about seventeen. She was muscular and wore a strange dress that, in her opinion, was supposed to bean traditional ork garment. She attached a multitude of small items to it, which were supposed to be orcish amulets. Some of them were maybe SOME amulets, some of them were caps ...

Despite her grumbling, Eti devoured three bowls, nibbling them with instant bread. Then Itel discreetly handed her the pills, which she ate without murmuring. Itel was a green haired elf with dark blue eyes and light brown skin. Her hair was pixie cut, her face was always focused. She looked at others distrustfully, unless someone seemed to be of use to her "grand plans" whatever they might be. Then she exploded with a slightly disturbing enthusiasm. She was wearing a red sleeveless sweatshirt. Her arms were tattooed with burning roses. There were Solarian symbols on her neck and face. She had undergone training two years ago and was now able to summon a silvery lunar blade. Out of the whole group, she was the most fierce and pushed the rest to all those crazy ideas that this trip was the culmination of.
"Damed Sidonius, I should have put a stake on him at the first opportunity"
After breakfast, they washed the dishes and prepared to inspect

the ship's systems. They had already left the Drift and would soon be landing on Saltmarsh, their final stop on the way into the unknown ... into the abyss. However, Itel was the first to gather peers for a different, more gloomy ritual. Bina didn't like him, but she understood that he was important to them… but… Itel, Alatar Lilka and Eti stood at the table and put their hands on it.

"Teeth for insult." Alatar said seriously.

"Language for a lie!" Lilka added

"Hand for punch!" said Eti.

"Eyes for an eye!" Itel shouted.

"Heart for betrayal." they called simultaneously and Itel cut over the palms of the others

They're really loved when they're not that scary. Thought bina After the system review, her charges went to training. The ship may have flown on autopilot for a while, so she had a moment to peer into a one place. She went to the hold and looked for a hidden biometric reader hidden in the alcove and touched it. A hidden hold opened. She went in there and looked around. Its contents did not change, Bina always preferred to check it regularly ... There was a cut-fridge with frozen tiger snail eggs and comet wasps, both species were extremely nasty predators guaranteeing very painful death. In the corner stayed huge machine with the jaws of a sea predator and claws like machetes, a Pk 5 assault robot that even the drow found too macabre. Halftons of explosives lay in the fireproof containers. With their help, they could destroy the city district. Thirty charges of gas that decompose the tissue and the second as many charges of

paralyzing gas were placed in a specially secured container. Six rock incinerators stood against the wall. Officially, it was only a mining tool that could easily burn through several dozen meters of rock. More dangerous was the fact that the radiation wave was killing everything within a kilometer. They were best known for the fact that the glow of the blast could blind everyone within a few kilometers. Only Two… or three people in the galaxy were able to activate them, due to the biometric lock, and one of them was Eti. And finally at the very end was their greatest treasure. One hundred kilotone atomic warhead. And she didn't count the equipment they had legally. She hid her face in her hands and laughed absolutely joylessly ...

"I let these kids carry Weapons of Mass Destruction with them ... I'm the worst mother in the galaxy."

Merciless

Tonado walked through the dark corridors of the Merciless, passing his subordinate crew members throwing them grimm looks. He was, after all, a recently appointed first mate on a pirate ship, and that required the ability to earn respect. As a Skittermander, it caused him many more problems. But he did his best for his great and wonderful captain! There was no other such a wonderful and fearless raider in the entire galaxy, and him, an ordinary pirate, was awarded such a responsible position. She personally promoted him after Reh-Zar was sent to do important task. It mean, he was now the captain's right-hand man. Figuratively. Or maybe not? The captain didn't have a right hand, but a prosthesis that always failed, so maybe he really was her right hand? As he thought about it, he puffed out his chest proudly, adjusted all six sabres, and headed for the sternum

There was they second mate Gydva, the one-eyed Veska big even for her race, the halfdrow boatswain Kaert, and artillerymen Chart who were android. Gydva didn't like Tonada because he had gotten the position she wanted. However, the Skittermander will not allow herself to be intimidated, even if he wasn't able to reach her knees, and she could throw him across the room. Kaert was formidable and militant, but Tonado even liked him, and Chart loved using their plasma artillery the most in the world. There was also Tirin, their navigator, but she rarely left the wheelhouse, and engineer Gozamund did a sub-drift inspection of their ship. In the captain's chair sat she, their captain. Moonshadow.

A tall woman dressed in a loose purple cloak was leaning over the monitor and studying the information displayed there. Half-short-cropped pinkish-purple hair protruded from the hood. On her face, beneath her purple eyes, she wore a pale mask of blue glass diamond. Many said it had terrible scars there, but the crew of merciless knew the truth was different. The right arm was replaced with a metal prosthesis, but it was not fully functional, so she was mainly using her left hand, which could also summon a

solarian flare. She was a formidable fighter, and of course his beloved mistress the captain.

"Hope all with ship is well Tonado?" She asked gently turning to the skitermander. She had a resonant voice only slightly muffled by the mask.

"Yes, Captain!" He exclaimed, saluting with all six hands. From the look in her eyes, he could tell she was smiling at him.

"Kaert, some of the crew may land, but be careful. This may be a dirt rock, but as far as I know it's full of dangerous bastards"

" Well, we'll have to buy as many strong beverages as possible and pay out future shares if the place we're traveling to is as terrible as they say " he said, eyeing the planet's image on the screen suspiciously. The brown-green globe was called Saltmarsh, and it was almost uninhabited, except for the city bearing the same name as this world and the small groups of nomads roaming the salt deserts and swamps.

" It is doubtful that the rumors at least reflect his nature in part." she said after a moment's thought, gently reaching to her back. " We're going to need all the crew members, so be careful. We have enough… resources to pay them…" She rubbed her temple irritably. "Remember the prize and the treasures that await us there…" Captain Moonshadow said. Kaert smiled greedily, but Gydwa wasn't so sure. He looked at her superiorly. He fought for the glory of serving under the greatest captain in the galaxy. Tirin and Gozamund served for the cause of the fight against Azlanti, and they would agree to any plan that served that goal

The captain got up and looked at Gydwa. Veska was larger in every way than Moonshadow, but under her gaze she drew back a little. She spoke slowly and clearly.

"Remember that I am not an ordinary robber. I fight and kill in the name of higher goals. Therefore, do not be offended like the kid

whose sweets were taken." she said and summoned a flare which she began slowly to Gydwa's face, who looked down scared.

"But do not worry. There we find riches beyond imagination." She added, extinguishing the flare violently so that Veska shuddered. The captain turned to Tonado.

"You will come with me. We have a few things to do. If the rumors I heard are true, we'll find something very interesting there."

Tonado felt his great Skittermander heart skip a beat. He will be on a wonderful, extraordinary and great expedition with his captain and they will have an adventure together ...

Captain Moonshadow was tired of talking to her crew, and there will be a lot of work to do in the next few days, especially if what she heard about certain people on Saltmarsh is true ... And then they'll fly into the unknown. She was afraid of that moment. She, the one for whose head the Aeon Throne had awarded a prize worth a little moon, the one who led her subordinates to the more numerous troops of the Aeon Guard, who started the rebellion on Jadehell, felt the greatest fear she remembered. But she had to travel to this ravaged area of the galaxy to get answers ... Answers to questions that had haunted her since she woke up in Absalon Station ...

She went to her cabin. The room was quite large and spacious, with almost no furniture except a sleeping mat and a few pillows. The walls were pale purple, lit by the soft glow of the elven lamps from Castroval, imitating the light of the stars… The stars… She liked their glow so much. They seemed to make an unspoken promise ... Their light brought hope that something better might be waiting for us somewhere, that it is always like the future, even if not perfect. She sealed the room and increased the pressure, then sat down on one of the cushions. She took off her mask and took a deep breath. She smiled. Contrary to what was commonly rumored among pirates and travelers, her face was not disfigured. It was not covered with a web of grotesque scars. The

mask helped her breathe. A ten-month stay at Jadehelll destroyed her lungs. Toxic secretions of the local flora and spores of poisonous fungi claimed the lives of thousands of prisoners. Nature on Jadehell didn't want to kill you. She did it casually, slowly and relentlessly. She was not in danger of suffocation even if she removed it. But then her breathing became short and she got tired very quickly. She unhooked the cybernetic prosthetic hand. Her body did not tolerate implants well, and she felt the constant pain of the phantom limb when she had an artificial arm attached. She lost her arm when she touched the starstone. It happened a few years ago, and it was her oldest memory. Everything was covered with white before ... The Doctor helped her bring out three memories. She spread her translucent wings with great difficulty. They suffered a lot of damage during questioning and staying in a penal colony. Now she protected them under her cloak, for they were only good for gliding anyway. She winced in pain and said.

"The sword I need to get hold of. The hand of the one who abandoned me and the head of the invader ..."

Whispering in the dark.

Arkan-tar stood in front of the mirror smiling with satisfaction. Its surface was smooth, with no reflection. Hungry Moon Mirror, as it was called. An ancient artifact from centuries ago, built by an ancient, now extinct race. So the standard in his work. He practiced applied archeology, called by outsiders the robbing of graves and the theft of relics . He touched the mirror and whispered softly in the aklo.

"Through nothingness together"

The mirror flashed and he saw the conference room of the battleship Glory of the Fallen, the flagship of the Research and Exploration Fleet. The room was beautifully decorated but not overwhelmingly lavish. it was almost cozy here . There was a similar mirror on the other side. Several people stayed in the conference room. The first and most important of these was Lord Admiral Antares. A tall and well-built man, he wore an elegant dress uniform. One eye was pale blue, as if glowing with a cold light. The second was cybernetic with an outer lens. His face was handsome but slightly asymmetrical. It was a memento of the gunshot that almost killed him. He was clean shaven and his dark red hair was cut short.

"Helo Arkan-tar and Lady Calo." he said to the twenty-year-old girl standing in the other mirror. She had long blond hair and deep blue eyes. She was dressed in a white dress with a deep cut so it wouldn't interfere with her jogging. At her side she wore an sword with an ornate hilt. On her finger was a ring with a red jewel cut through with green metal veins. Around her neck she wore medalion with a clasp, which probably contained a picture of a loved one. Lady Cala Grayskull bowed courtly.

"Also hello to all gathered." She said in a beautiful melodious voice.

"I hope your journey was peaceful," the Lord Admiral asked in a formal tone.

"The beginnings were good, but we were attacked by pirates in orbit Saltmarh. Only me and Miss Daisy survived, but we had to make an emergency landing and our ship is severly damaged. We need a new…" said the aristocrat in a gentle voice. Antares nodded.

"We will discuss this issue later. But first we must introduce ourselves and discuss the matters for which we are gathered here, he said, and pointed the man to his right. He was tall, with short hair, and somewhat androgynous features. He wore a well-groomed uniform, and his face was overly serious.

"This is Commander Reese, my right hand." the admiral said.

"And I'm his left, better hand. Or, more officially, an information and intelligence officer. Call me Lady Ka," said a rather short woman with an emerald-decorated mask over the right half of her face. She was pale, her pupils were dilated, and she was smiling menacingly with one half of her mouth. Antares grunted and pointed to another woman. She was dressed in a scarlet cloak with a hood. Only the lower pale half of the face was visible. The face was beautiful, but the woman emanate an aura of fear. She twirled a finger around a lock of fiery red hair.

"This is Lady Sorrowflame. Our science and technology oficer" said the Lord Admiral, and the woman bowed and said.

"Indeed, it was nice meeting you."

The last person introduced himself.

"On behalf of the Order of the Eclipse, I have come to fulfill the mission given to me by the Lictor himself. I am the Lady of the Blades of Asindes Di Vir, said the tall woman with golden hair, clad

in the armor of the knights of hell with the crest of the Order on her breast. The coat of arms depicted the sun during an eclipse. She was a beautiful and well-built woman in her forties. There was an acid scar on her cheek. At her belt she wore an archeotechnical sword in a slightly too small scabbard,

Lady Ka chuckled hearing Asindesa's words, but the Lord Admiral motioned for her to remain silent

"Now that we've introduced ourselves, lets me remind you of the reason why we're here.- Antares began in a serious tone." Five years ago there was a terrible event. Many planets, from Vescariuum to the Pact Worlds, have fallen victim to the attack. From the center of the Ravaged Zone, a signal was emitted that appeared to be the beginning of the activation of weapons of unimaginable power that not only was able to wipe out entire planets and their trillions of inhabitants, but possibly wipe them out of reality. A few months later, the whole thing happened again. As we can all guess, it caused a great stir among the rulers, although the public did not find out about anything. It was discovered that a previously unknown planet had appeared in place where the signal came from. Originally, it was decided to send there a joint vesk - pact flotilla to pacify or permanently destroy this place. However, there were some obvious difficulties. First of all, this planet is located in the so-called Ravaged Zone, an area of the galaxy hitherto unexplored, from where no signals are coming. Most of the expeditions sent there did not return, and the few that did bring disturbing news. Legends of white demons and such tales. By analyzing the structure of the Ravaged Zone, the scientists guessed that this was the area of the Swarm's operation. I do not intend to argue with this thesis, but the fact is that the area is devoid of drift transmitters, which makes any exploration of it with a large navy seems extremely difficult. For several years, policymakers thought about what to do with this new and completely unknown threat, until two people found a solution to most of the problems. The first was Lady Cala Grayskull of Carurystal, present here." he pointed to the young lady who bowed politely " She is in possession of ancient maps depicting that area. They are said to come from the time of the

founder of the family Mara, who is said to have come from that place is called Etheria.

"I should find all these "Seems" and "Apparently" offensive. While it is not certain that the line of Mara has not been broken during all these millennia, the origin of Mara, as well as the nature of Etheri itself, are not in doubt."

The admiral raised his hand in agreement.

"I'm a mercenary and a military man. I do not penetrate into historical and legendary issues. This is where we come to my participation in this entire mission. For the last thirty years, since I was banished from my home planet, I have fought in various conflicts, mainly with a Swarm, but also in local conflicts. It has its own fleet, used to operate independently, away from the supply line, outside the command structure. When, thanks to my numerous contacts among representatives of the authorities, I found out about this project, I decided to join it. The government paid me in advance, regardless of the results. So the reason for my presence, and my allies and Lady Caly's, are understandable. Now it is the turn of the explanation of the reason for the presence of Arkkan-tar." He looked significantly at Verthani. Arkan bowed low and said

"We were sent here to be the first to travel deep into the Ravaged Zone. Our first goal is to make sure that this is not an area of swarm activity. In addition, our task will be to determine the route for the fleet to move. We are also supposed to gather all the data on the potential threats that may await us there. After all, if we manage to reach this Etheria, we are to find out, in the most discreet way possible, what threatened the rest of the universe and, if necessary, neutralize this weapon. There is no mention of the fact that we should survive, but that goes without saying ... Or not ... -He smiled grimly.- As I understand it, since Lady Grayskull has lost her ship, our task is also to find a suitable means of transport. I understand that we will get adequate funds to get the ship? - Arkan asked matter-of-factly.

Lord Admiral noded.

"In fact, I thought in advance that the Lady Grayskull vehicle might not meet the requirements of a mission of this rank, so I deposited in hotel where you are staying with a credstick containing half a million credits with the possibility of a loan of up to two million." Antares bowed apologetically to Lady Caly.
Lady Ka chuckled.

"Don't think you can steal it or anything like that. Our tentacles are long indeed and our claws are sharp…" She chuckled again.

"You have to buy or rent a ship that will survive such a difficult journey. It can be difficult in a place like Saltmarsh, but you can count on few outside this planet knowing about the mission. There are forces in the universe that intend to hinder this mission… or overtake us. Discretion is therefore of the utmost importance. You have the papers that you are doing a job for Kemanis University." The Lord Admiral looked significantly at the Arcan." Some even worked for him. Pretend to be seekers of ancient knowledge and archaeologists.

"That means graveyard hyenas who are operating legaly." said Lady. Ka, smiling sarcastically.

"Doctor Qin and his intern will be waiting for you at the docks. You will need them in case you need technical support. The doctor was present at the listening center during the attack, and she knows a lot, a little more than nothing. Then you will find Lady Cala and her guardian, Miss Daisy. Next contact through the mirrors will happen tomorrow, when you are all assemble."

Arkana nodded and, touching the mirror, spoke in Aklo.

"Nothingness will consume everything."

The Awesome trio of strangers

Arkan-tar rubbed his glasses thoughtfully. He did not expect this mission to be easy and his expectations came true. Journey to a mysterious planet that appeared out of nowhere, and the discovery of which was related to such dramatic events, could seem like a wonderful adventure, but only in the minds of ignorant people. He had been an archaeologist and seeker of the secrets of ancient races for years, so he had no illusions that instead of adventure, blood, sweat and tears awaited them. Arkan, however, accepted it, because the prize they could win was beyond al. imagination ... if, of course, they lived long enought to enjoy it.

He looked at his reflection in the small mirror hanging on the wall of his cabin. Like among all Verthani, the inhabitants of Versec, who was trapped between day and night, his eyes were completely black, with no whites. He could change the color of his skin, but he liked to keep it uniform in a shade of gray. His hair was cut short and gray. He usually smiled, mysteriously and somewhat cunningly. He was not very handsome, but also not ugly. He adjusted his glasses, an extremely valuable gift that the Doctor had given him ... Sometimes they let him experience the distant past, the echoes of past and forgotten times. Ancient artifact from the lost Golarion… or somewhere else. He's never known in his story.

As he left the cabin, he covered the Hungry Moon Mirror with a sheet. Then he ordered the port staff to transport it to the hotel ”End of begining”, where they were to stay. He wondered if the crew thought he was narcis because he needed two mirrors. He left the Absalonian freighter Endless Voyage on which he was brought to Saltmarsh. The ship came here to buy fly cakes, fly nap, fly dust. He saw a clear pattern in the commodities exported by this planet. As soon as he left the harbor building, far too large for a place forgotten by gods and men, he felt the hot hammer of

the sun hit him in the face. He left Versec many years ago and had spent most of his life in dark places or aboard spaceships, so his eyes had become weaned from the harsh light.

He put on his hat and went to the little cafe where his other two traveling companions had stayed. One of them was a relatively short lashuntian women with silvery hair and a swarthy complexion named Rechiza. The eyes were what was caugh the eye. Instead of typically insect, they were dull gray with hundreds of pores visible, as if someone were trying to combine typical Lashuntian eyes with human-like. She was Damaya, and therefore distinguished by a mental acuity that made up for her delicate build. She had lost her antennae, supposedly in the same accident that she lost her eyes, but he wasn't sure because she hadn't said anything about it and he hadn't pushed it. She pretended to be an archaeologist, but was a cult hunter in the service of hellknights, but was unaware that he knew her true profession, or that she knew who designed her eyes. She was quite talkative during the trip, but very skillfully avoided talking about topics related to her profession and the reason why she joined thisjourney. What is certain is that she knew much more than the rest.

"What did the Lord Admiral have to tell us that was so important that we couldn't be present during this conversation?" she said, smiling sourly.

"Theoretically, I am in charge of this expedition, so I represented all of us, but I agree. Next time we will participate in the conference together, then I will not have to repeat to you everything what has already been said" said Arkan, trying to sound as polite as possible. The other woman snorted contemptuously

.
"Oh, this is too much grace. What your companions might care about what could happen to them as they travel through the most gods cursed corner of the galaxy." Dilayla said grimly.

She was a tall half-elf from the Minitar, a distant and almost forgotten planet somewhere deep in the Vast. Her hair was cut short and bangs was light blue in color. A strand of scars cut across her cheek, a trail of shards that had hit her in some explosion long ago. She lost her arms, which were replaced with cybernetic prostheses, as was her right leg. She wore the symbol of Iomadae around her neck. Little is known about her past, except that she lost her family in a mysterious attack by Dominion of Black and was saved by the Hellknights. She was much less effusive than Rechiza, so she was simply silent most of the journey. Arkana did not mind too much, as he did not require too much eloquence from their weapon specialist. Nevertheless, he would prefer to embark on such a long journey in an atmosphere of friendship.

Trust is not our forte Verthani thought.

Dilayla could handle power armor and heavy weapons, so in the event of an emergency, she had the lion's share of responsibility for the survival of the three of them. At least in theory, because thanks to implants and exocortex, he was able to use a long weapon very efficiently when needed, and Rechiza was a witchwarper and could recall fragments of reality from other worlds. So it is good that in confrontation with enemies they were able to take care of themselves.

"Your sarcasm is unnecessary. We will spend the next six months together and we have to live together somehow. I understand that this task may seem to us all full of threats, not only the obvious ones".

" I understand you, but I hope that in the future we will be treated as equal members of this team?" Rechiza said in a serious voice, her metallic eyes puncturing him. Arkan bowed low and said in agreement.

"It will be so" and then he summarized the entire conversation for them. Dilayla sipping her coffee *just like from Golarion* snorted at the end, almost spitting on Verthani and Lashunta."So, as I

understand it, we will be babysitting some rich girl" her old decrepit nanny and unlucky scientist? Has anyone gone completely crazy, as if the trip to what most likely is the gateway to the dimension of anguish was a walk.

"From what Arkan said, Lady Cala looks like a competent person who will be able to take care of herself, so you won't have to change hers diaper. As far as I know, her family has ruled Grayskull Castle for hundreds of years before The Gap. Most likely, he is the last representative of this highly respected family. Miss Daisy has recently been living in Carurystal, and she enjoys a certain amount of respect there. She is a mansion manager and a sorceress valued even beyond this rather rustic planet." the Lashunti said thoughtfully.

"Grayskull? It was a family of pirates or necromancers?" Dilayla asked with a scowl.

"In past? Who can know? Now? It was a respectable, well-mannered family, albeit quite unlucky."

"I can see that you prepared well." The warrior asked, smiling sadly.

"I always try to be prepared" said Rechiza seriously.

"But the one time you lost your eyes, you weren't" Dilayla said with a malicious smile and got up from the table. "Lead Arkan,, let's get it all over with."
The scholar Verthani bowed to her and clearly irritated Lashuntia and led her back to the hotel

The end of the beginning

Rechiza tried to suppress her anger at the soldier, but it was not easy. Since that… Accident, she had not been able to fully accept her condition, though it wasn't the loss of eyes that hurt her the most. Her eyesight ... Well, these implants had some advantages. She saw with a previously unknown depth and tenderness. However, her view angle was narrower and she did not perceive colors naturaly. She recognized colors but couldn't see them normally, so the world was gray and colorless to her. However, that was not the biggest problem. The implant had an artificial intelligence whose goals and objectives she could not define. She felt as if her eyes were telling her to notice certain things and they almost burned into her memory. But that didn't bother her, she was much more worried that they might have hidden certain things from her that were crucial to her work.

But in terms of eyesight, hers capabilities had improved. The loss of telepathy and the Lashuntian senses hurted a lot more. She felt as if someone had taken a piece of her soul from her, as if she had been torn from the world forever. No non-lashunta, with the possible exception of the Shiren, understood the pain, and at the same time it was their closeness that caused her the most sufering. Knowing that they could so easily touch the minds of other beings, and she was cut off forever... Perhaps she could somehow recreate their abilities through technological implants, but decided not to try. The risk was too great.
The problem was that about a quarter of the people of Saltmarsh were Shirens, mostly living on hydroponic farms or catching those damned flies. The rest of the population were Vesks, mainly those expelled from Veskarium or unable to cope with its strict, militaristic society. The same was true of the surprisingly large population of the local drow who preferred to live on that ball of salt rather than die on the Apostate.

Saltmarsh was colonized about a hundred years ago. Although due to the increase in sun activity, large tracts of land became deserts, and many seas turned into salt marshes ... The basis of the ecosystems were huge swarms of flies, butterflies and dragonflies, mostly eating algae growing in salt waters. The living conditions here were not easy, but compared to such an Akiton, not to mention Eox or Aukturn, it was quite a pleasant place. It was not the natural conditions that prevented the sapient beings from further colonizing the planet, but the fear of the unnamed menace lurking in the ravaged zone. Expeditions sent there usually disappeared without a trace. The few who returned told stories of white demons, or the lord of the seven heavens, or someone who dispersed the shadows. Most had no idea what was really going on there. In this universe full of demons and devils, anything was possible. Rechiza, however, knew the truth… which looked worse than one might imagine.

They came to a hotel, the most luxurious on the planet, which in a place like this meant that there would be no vermin here and no one would rob them. Mainly because the owner probably paid of the most dangerous gang in the city or was even a member of it. The building had eight floors, making it one of the tallest buildings in the city. At the reception desk a exaggerated polite drow waited an exaggeration, and the entrance was guarded by two menacing-looking Vesks. Dilayla smiled as she studied the bar, but Rechiza snorted. She avoided all kinds of stimulants, not counting herbal teas. Her job required an absolutely clear mind. After all, the enemy could be lurking absolutely anywhere. A girl with white hair, almond-shaped eyes, wearing gloves and glasses for the deaf, was waiting for them at the foot of the stairs. When she saw them, she waved at them and spoke in sign language.

"Hello! I'm Rosie Pearl! Everyone is already upstairs" translated the electronic translator wearing gloves.

Rechiza sighed. She hoped she would have some time to freshen up after the long journey and take a normal bath instead of the marineshower she'd had in recent weeks. She was used to discomfort, which didn't mean she liked it. Arkan must have

already found a place where there is a bathhouse and he will sneak out to use it unnoticed, and Dilalyla has probably already had that one nasty, wet day of the year behind her. She laughed at this unintentional ambiguity. The half-elf scowled at her as if she understood what the Lashunti laughed at.

As they entered the double suite they had rented for them, they were greeted by a tall blonde girl, or rather a young woman, who hugged each of them, though Dilayla almost pushed her away. She was surprisingly strong for someone brought up in luxury.

"Hi! I am Lady Cala Grayskull from Carurystal. There is my teacher and homeroom teacher, Mrs. Daisy" she pointed to an armchair in the corner of the room.

An elf about forty years of her race sat on it. She had dark green hair and gray skin. She drank her tea thoughtfully, but when she saw them, she said.

"I am glad to meet my companions of such a wonderful journey ..." she said grimly.

Ysoki was standing in the doorway to the neighboring apartment, looking as if her life goal was to get rid of as many biological organs as possible. When she saw Rosie, she called out to her.

"Where have you been? We have so many boxes to open and my intern is wandering around somewhere!

"I do not hang around, but welcome rest of travel companions. And why do we have to open these boxes when we're going to be leaving anyway." Rosie said.

Ysoka tapped the cybernetic eye.

"You are an intern and it is your responsibility to do what your employer tells you to do!" She crossed her arms over her chest and then, seeing the guests, ran to Miss Daisy and took the kettle with the cutlery from her.

"Please, take it, don't be shy" said the elf resignedly.

"I'm Dr. Qin, and the other one is Rosie Pearl" Ysoka said as she poured a cup for them and began to sprinkle sugar.

"And you asked if I wanted tea?" Dilayla snapped and sat down in the armchair, glaring at the other

"I don't want tea either" Lashunti said, and sat a bit to the side to keep an eye on everyone. Only Arkan accepted a treat in the form of tea or more corectly sugar syrup with tea flavour.

"So the ladies got to the hotel ahead of us?" Verthani asked smiling gently.

"he ship is too damaged to repair it anyway, maybe I can sell the parts before departure. Without this, we have sixteen thousand credits for private expenses. Two times more if I can sell the ship parts well" Cala said.

"A lot to drink, but the money will end quickly if we buy the right equipment. You probably don't know the prices of weapons, do you?" Dilayla asked with her perpetually sour expression.

"You took enough weapons to win a smal war anyway, so don't whine." Rechiza said, carefully examining the apartment in which they will spend the next few days. Most of the furniture was imported, and although it was of fairly good quality, it showed signs of wear and was completely randomly selected. The windows were tight, which was to protect the members of the household against daily flies, which could theoretically lead to death by suffocation. There was a screen on the wall that was protected against breaking by an additional glass.

"I would like to remind you that we are flying to a place where the inhabitants were deliberately trying to destroy half of the known universe. In such a situation, there is no such thing as enough weapons" Dr. Qin said.

Miss Daisy smiled indulgently.

"If the inhabitants of that planet had weapons that could destroy worlds on such a scale, i doubt whatever you find on Saltmarsh or anywhere else will matter." She said grimly.

Rechiza listened to her with one ear, because there was something strange in the face of the gray-skinned elf. As if her face had smeared, pixelated. It looked as if she was wearing a holographic mask.

"In my opinion, you always have to be ready for anything, just as a matter of principle." the Lashunti replied, looking at the elf. *Do not trust anyone*'

Shadow of the past – The Carurystal’s rain

She woke up.
She slept on a narrow bed under a wool blanket. The room was cool, although Grayskull Castle had heating. They also didn't have to turn off the radiators to save money. She preferred the cold, she had nappijnng better. She slept briefly, at most two or three hours. Not only because her body hardly needed him anymore. When she where closing her eyes, memories of the life she wanted so much to leave behind her returned ...

She washed and changed from a nightgown to her black robe, made in the style recently fashionable on the Seagull Coast. Years have passed since she could afford to think about what is fashionable. It was almost unnatural…. Then she put on a holographic mask and signaled to the maid with a bell that she was ready. Leris, a young and polite Half-Elf with ash-colored hair and a shy smile, entered her chambers.

"Good morning Miss Daisy, I hope you had a good night's sleep." she asked cheerfully

"As good as always." *its means horrible,* she said, trying to be polite

"Tea was brewed, can i serve the marmalade cakes?" The maid entered the room looking at her employer with concern. She used to think there were ulterior motives behind a girl's protectiveness, but eventually concluded that Leris genuinely worried about her. It was as surprising as it was unnecessary. She had been survived so much that ordinary nightmares could not harm her.

Oh yeah, I survived ... she thought and laughed mournfully, but then she said.

"Yes serve the cakes. I will eat them with joy."

She drank tea on a balcony with a tastefully made decorative metal fence. She was protected from the rain by a wooden roof, although she could asked for a force field, but she feel resentment to them... Besides, she liked to watch the rain. For many years she had been deprived of his view. On Caturystal, and especially in Seagull's coast, it rained frequently, though not continuously, as was believed on other worlds. She couldn't get used to the mass media, but she liked the radio, especially when anything other than military reports was broadcast. Then she went to her office, where she took care of replying to letters and e-mails, although fortunately there were not many of them. She still hadn't battled her aversion to computers, and the idea of the Internet, even as simple as on Carurystal, troubled her.

Then breakfast was brought to her: a soft-boiled egg and bread with honey. After more than thirty years of eating nasty food rations and drinking moonshine from the technical department stocks, even the simplest normal food was wonderful. Then a more important documents was brought to her, including those relating to the management of Lady Caly's estate. Her… ward was not in the top ten of the richest landowners, but in the top thirty yes already. Thousands of people lived on hers land, and she also owned fishing vessels, cattle, and even an amber mine. Lady Cala was a very good candidate for marriage as a beautiful, healthy, rich and bright girl. The only hers drawback was that she was adopted. Otherwise, it would be worth thinking about finding her husband or wife whih was expected. But their plans were different. That is why she had always refused all requests, and now she had once again reviewed the letter they had received from the ealrless Karintes of Blackmoor, who offered the hand of one of her twin children: the Son Demestin, or the daughter Demestines. There was something oddly tempting about the idea of arranged marriages. They put order in place of the emotional chaos that always irritated and terrified her. Perhaps a mock engagement could be arranged. This could be a very enlightening lesson for Lady Caly. The ability to conduct courtship was something that would surely come in handy on the upcoming Great Mission, especially since she couldn't give her any advice in

that regard… at least useful advice. Unfortunately, she was afraid that with Lady Caly's temperament, it might end in a tragic way.

"Should I ask to saddled horses for the afternoon." Leris asked looking into her office. She thought for a moment, then replied. "Yes, I'd love to go for a ride. " she said, and the half-elven servant smiled.

After work, she went on a tour of the property. She had known for a long time that the sight of a superior had a positive effect on subordinates. They need to know that someone is keeping an eye on them, but also that someone cares about their work. For years, it was one of her daily duties, until her health made it impossible. She shook her head, trying to chase away her thoughts.

People greeted her politely, though avoiding looking her in the face. Not out of fear, as was the case in the old days, but out of common courtesy. Her scars and deformities were no secret. It would be too hard to hide them. So they knew she had an accident involving using a spell that was too powerful, which happened quite often after all, and that was usually the end of the discussion. Few suspected more, and almost no one knew the truth. Even she did not know the full consequenccess of her deed until it was too late.

Residents saw in her the caretaker of the young Lady Cala. Everyone remembers that she was a strange, quiet child who suffered a series of tragedies. Starting with abandonment, ending with the death of most of the family. It was Miss Daisy who made her the life and soul of the society, a lady who personified the ideals of the Carurystal aristocracy. Therefore, most of the residents were positive about the new property manager, despite her undoubted quirks and gruff character. They did not know the truth, and it is better that they never know it.

She stood near the training plaza, where a group of young people of both sexes, or even more than both, trained under the supervision of the famous fencer Therstigos Arandel from Castroval. Although Carurystal was famous for its excellent fencing

masters, she decided Lady Cala would need some familiarization with the culture of other planets. Besides, she wanted to learn about the true elven culture, little known where she was born. Therstigos was a good teacher, who taught both court and real fencing, but also the basics of dance, etiquette and elven language. At first, Cala was reluctant to learn fencing because she insisted that she didn't need any weapons, which was true in some way But she could not reveal her full potential without revealing the truth about herself. Besides, it was worth to teach her that death and destruction are not always the best solution.

Today Cala was not in the square, so she did not stay longer. Her ward was now in the capital, Lynortis, where she had *Their Affairs* to attend to. She didn't like the phrase very much, but she couldn't help it. Dr. Rephan, Lady Cala's personal physician, was also present in the square, and the only person in the castle who was sure to serve the same principal as she.The Doctor was short, bald and always cheerful. He had lived here from Cali's earliest childhood and cared for her health. Or rather, he made sure that no one got to know her… unique anatomy. She didn't like him, with mutuallty, but they tried not to get in each other's way ... She walked through numerous chambers and corridors of the castle until she came to the stable. There were many horses here. Some of them reacted nervously to her presence. Fortunately, horses from ancient Geb, where the undead ruled ,were bred on Caryrustal, and the cursed elf was no big deal to them. Her own mare. Shade was saddled. She was small, gray, very gentle. Most of her life she hadn't kept animals, not for company anyway, but for much darker purposes. But in Carurystal she fell in love with horses and horse riding. It took her several months to study, but she was always a learned student. She looked at the lonely stall of the corner of the stable, separate from the others. It was the Black Wind stall. Lady Caly's horse. At first she thought the coincidence of names was amusing or proving the petty jealousy of her ward, until she found out whose name it was, and since then she could not be around the huge black stallion without feeling quite justified anxiety.

She had changed into horse riding clothes and now she is wearing a raincoat. The weather in the coast of Seagulls was changeable. She was waiting for her mount to be saddled, when Leris entered the stables.

"May I go for a ride with you, Miss Daisy. The girl asked timidly." She shrugged.

"Why not? If you have time." she answered her.

They left Grayskull Castle through the main gate. She looked back, examining the massive body of the ancient fortress. The structure was as majestic as it was devoid of any defensive qualities, even when was built centuries ago, during the last wave of colonization. Another thing could be said about the cavernous vaults that stretched under the entire peninsula on which the castle was built. When she thought about it, she wished she had been able to visit a certain place in the old days… It is in the basement of Lady Cal's castle that the evidence of her origin ... She snorted and chased the horse, and Leris followed. The Carz Peninsula was famous for its high cliffs, stretching majestically over the blue-gray sea. It was quite a risky ride for an untrained rider like her. In Carurystal, riding skill was common, even when it came to mechanical mounts, so Leris probably had more experience than she did, at least in this regard.
She stopped and began to look around her. The sea was slightly rough to the north and east, and to the south and west there were green pastures and groves. Here and there, she saw single buildings. There was a solid, lead-gray cloud layer overhead. The wind blew her hair. *I really like this life.* She thought and felt tears welling up in her eyes.

"Is something wrong, Miss Daisy?" Leris asked.

"Oh, life happened ... Just life." she replied, wiping her eyes.

She ate leek soup and some roast for dinner, then looked into her garden and took care of the management of the castle. And then dusk began to get closer, and she felt the weight on her shoulders

growing. Finally she went to her retreat and had a fire lit in the fireplace and order to brought a bottle of brandy. She could see the concern in Leris's eyes as she handed her the bottle and glass, but she wasn't about to change her mind. She spent the next few hours sitting in an armchair, staring at the flames and thinking. In the red sparks she saw the advancing columns of troops, the flashes of explosions and the fear in the eyes of those who stood in her way. In the sound of burning wood, she heard the roar of working machines, the screams of the dying and the crying of children. The smell of smoke smelled of oil and spilled blood… They were painful and terrible memories, but she had no intention of running away from them. Though it meant little, of course ...

There was the sound of a heavy hardwood double door swinging open, and she heard footsteps. Delicate as the sound of a spider treading. Full of hidden strength worthy of a predator waiting for an opportunity. Lady Cala sat on the armchair next to him.

"I like to look at the flames." said the girl with a gentle smile.

"I don't doubt it." she told her. *What is nightmare for one, is dream for another*

There was a tense silence like there was so often when they were left alone.

" I received a letter today proposing an engagement ..."she finally said to Lady Cala.

" It might actually be quite funny." Cala answer, and giggled

"And that's why I refused."She said firmly.

They were silent for a moment again.

"There comes a moment when we will have to leave Carurystal." when the girl said this, her teacher felt a cold sweat pour over her "A philosopher said that life is an eternal homecoming." she continued "Another said that existence determinnes consciousness. The few years you spent here have had an impact

on you. You're used to this life. A life as comfortable as it is false. If people knew the truth ... though probably many might not believe it." Lady Cala smiled at her. Few saw that this beautiful, delicate face and lovely eyes blue like mountain lakes concealed an eminently alien mind.

"How much time do I have." she asked resignedly.

"A bit. A couple of months, at least. An independent expedition is being organized to reach a mysterious planet that the inhabitants were to use weapon against the known worlds. Admiral Antares volunteered to lead the expedition. I have to meet this man and get us into this venture somehow ... Maybe it will be better this way. It was very difficult for us to assemble a fleet of sufficient strength without arousing suspicion.

"You are sure that your training is over?" she asked, processing the words of her pupil.

Lady Cala laughed out loud.

"I am stronger, smarter, and better educated than anything else I can meet at my destination, and besides, there are forces as old as the universe behind me."
She smiled at the girl's words.

"Such thinking can easily lead to loss. I know something about this."

Lady Cal looked at her thoughtfully for a moment. Then she got up and put her hand on her tutor's shoulder.

"You know ... We are in many ways like mother and daughter. And like all offspring, I want to be in every way a more perfect version of my parent." she kissed her on the cheek. The holographic mask blurred for a moment. Then Lady Cala left the room to go about her own affairs .. Her tutor took the bottle and went to the balcony. That night, he will not sleep anymore. She will listen to the Carurystal’s rain.

Conversations under the crimson sun.

"Forgive me Itel, but what are we doing on this lump of salt cursed by the gods and daemons?" Eti asked, She was dressed in the outfit of an Akiton nomad, although she did not have a dust filter yet, and she wear goggles that shielded her sensitive cat eyes from the light of the local scorching sun. She wore falcon boots that allowed her to walk on walls and ceilings.

The green-haired elf rolled her eyes.

"Bina is here to stock up on the expedition." She replied.

Eti ostentatiously looked around. She saw a rickety bush. She walked over to him and started talking to him.

"Hey Bina. It's nice that you took us shopping. I was just about to show you what I would like you to buy me for this beautiful trip. Headcheese, brass knuckles, explosives." - she gestured theatrically

Itel narrowed her eyes.

"Would you mind not fooling around?" She said irritably.

Eti turned abruptly to the elf and came so close that they looked each other straight in the eye

"Of course I could, but why if I can't do what I want, and you know what I want to do? Absolutely nothing, and that could be the last chance before flying to the Ravaged Zone, or where we're going…" She said in a calm voice not matching the clenched metal hand. She didn't like to raise her voice, it always didn't seem to suit someone like her. So someone absolutely perfect, amazing and unique.

"But for the last two weeks ..." Itel bit her tongue, but Eti moved closer to her and picked up goggles.

"Come on, say it ... " she drawled.

Itel blushed ashamed. She stepped back and sighed.

"Bina always says that she does not like taking us shopping, because we are intimidating the sellers" explained her friend, but Eti interrupted her.

"But we really are scary. This is our specialty and we should not be ashamed of it." Eti said seriously. She felt pride growing in her heart.

"But these are almost certainly not the talents Bina needs." Alatar said, not looking up from the datapad, playing a game without too much involvement. Lilka was lying on the white sand and moving her hands up and down.

"What are you doing Lilka?" Itel asked, standing next to Eti,

"I make an eagle in the sand" said the self-styled orcish in a slightly bored voice. Her fiery ax lay beside her.

"Of course Bina needs such talents." continued Eti "Our power of persuasion would surely make any trader drop the price, and even add something extra. - She came up to the dragonfly holding her hips.

"Most likely he would just take a gun out from under the counter or call security ... Or both." said Alatar, interrupting the game.

"Or maybe it's salt." Lilka wondered aloud.

Eti wanted to say something about what she thought about salespeople and what they can do with their security, but Itel cut in.

"Bina didn't take us, but we can't do nothing with it. But she didn't tell us what to do, did she?" The elf said putting her hand on Eti's shoulder.

"Pfe Pfe, it's sand with salt. Lilka began to spit the sand she wanted to eat.

"She told us not to get into trouble" Alatar corrected Solarian.

The shooter snorted and gently slipped her arm out of Itel's, then crossed her arms over her chest.

"My dear, we are the troubles others get into" she said firmly. Itel sighed irritably.

"Could you just focus on what I'm saying for a moment!" She screamed. Eti turned to her.

"We are always perfectly focused and nothing ever distracts us"nsaid Eti with absolute certainty.

"What a lovely pebble!" Lilka said, and she walked over to a flat red stone covered with a pretty mosaic.

Eti and Itel looked at each other for a moment, bewildered, Finally Eti grabbed the end of the braid and began to nervously massage the inside of the metal hand with it. In the morning, she dyed her hair red-white and braided it so that the braid looked like a two-color spiral.

"Okay, Itel, I'm listening carefully ... W hat's your plan?"

Itel smiled, clearly pleased that she could finally share her plan with her friends. She put the datapad on the portable table and turned on the map of the neighborhood, which she must have pulled from the poor local network, then opened her notes.

"First of all, it is a place located on the border of the Ravaged Zone and from here all expeditions set off when you still wanted

to organize them. For sure, the locals still remember a lot what it was like and maybe someone who took part in one of the few expeditions whose members were not murdered still lives here."

Eti grimaced understanding what her friend was going to.

"So we have to look for someone who did not run to the other end of the galaxy as soon as his foot left the deck of the expedition ship and convince him to tell us all about it? It's trivial."

"Actually, you better leave the part about persuasion to us." Itel said carefully, but Eti leaned towards her. She narrowed her eyes.

"But I can be very persuasive!" She said, grinning her sharp teeth slowly.

"Rather frightening." muttered Alatar.

"It's not a pebble, it has legs ... It's a Bug." Lilka shouted, and grabbed the fiery ax. The others moved away from her to out of range of their weapons, but did nothing else.

"Ftightening is the same as persuasive." she said, feeling pleased with the unexpected praise.

"No, that's different." Alatar muttered, but Itel, after thinking, said.

"It's a good idea, actually. If you can "convince" them without drawing attention to yourself and without risking yourself, then do so."

Eti smiled. As soon as she finds someone who has survived the expedition to the Ravaged Zone, it will make him regret

"You'll like the second part of the plan less. We need someone who knows something about ancient artifacts and searching the ruins ..." said Solarian. Eti frowned. This was not an idea typical of Itel, who usually suspected everyone of slitting their throats or selling them to their enemies.

"It wasn't a bug, it was a crab. Poor crab." said Lilka and came up to them "Where are the ruins?"

"So far nowhere, although knowing our style of work, they may soon appear somewhere." Itel muttered

"I'm sorry, but I think we got Ilemshaw and Ireanis for that." Eti said. She didn't like the prospect of letting strangers aboard their ship for a few months… to their only home.

"Ilemashaw can't leave the tank, and Ireanis is very… Ireanis and we can't really count on her. Besides, we need someone who knows the past and is not a relic of it. Who knows about Magitech and Archeotech. You understand?" Iitel asked. Lilka with a smile on her lips shook her head negatively.

"Honestly, I don't understand. - said Eti with absolute honesty "But I will look for ... How did you describe it? Archeotech specialist… maybe an archaeologist or historian?" She asked, leaning her head resignedly on the metal hand " Though to be honest I have no idea how." She sighed and caught a fly flying by.

"And now what is most important. We have to find the observatory and get to it." She said with a sly smile.

She actually liked that idea. Doctor leech was supposed to conduct research here, but how much can you trust a deadctor?

"But what exactly are you going to find there? We have the maps Sidonius gave you. I guess they're accurate enough?" She asked, hoping that it would not turn out right away that she had organized the entire trip without knowing how to get there. Maybe it didn't matter to her, she didn't care much for antyhing, but Bina and the rest agreed to the undertaking, hoping that the solarian had an idea of what she was doing.

"They are, but I'd rather make sure they don't have any mistakes, or that he hasn't hidden something from us. Plus, the record might still be there" Itel said, trying not to show how much she was looking forward to getting the video. Alatar looked sour.

"We have to go all over the planet because you want to prove something Bina?" He said with a total lack of enthusiasm.

"Not the whole planet, there is one big city ... The observatory must be nearby." said itel with exaggerated optimism. Eti shook her head, not knowing what to think, but she said.

"Okay, so maybe I will look for people who once went to the Ravaged Zone, you will learn something about the observatory, and each of us will try to look for a scientist who somehow ended up in such a hole." She said looking at the others. She didn't like to take the lead on their package, but she knew someone had to end this discussion because Bina would come back from shopping and they would still be arguing. "Does anyone have some credit for me for business expenses? She asked in an innocent voice.

Itel was already reaching into her pocket to hand her the Credstick, but Alatar put his hand on the elf's shoulder.

"You know, this is probably not the best idea. Bina would be angry too." he said gently to Eti. The shooter sighed *It was worth a try*

"Okay, then I'll see you at sunset, or when we find something interestin." she said and put on her goggles and a dust mask and headed for the city.

Sunny day

Eti has never liked being on sight. She always felt content to observe others by herself being invisible. She turned on the cloaking and tried to stay in the shade or on the rooftops, so she went unnoticed without any problems. Saltmarsh was a small city, at least compared to the metropolises of Atrax and Akiton, but it was densely built and crowded. After all, it was the only significant trade hub on the planet. This made it easier to hide without hindering her obtaining the information she had come here for.

Their ship landed a few kilometers outside the city, near a salt lake, allowing everyone to take a hot shower. Bina took the Crushey, so unfortunately Eti had to go to Saltmarsh on her own feet. It took some effort, but she was used to long hikes in the heat of the desert sun during all those years on Akiton… Okay, these years have not been so many after all. Contrary to her appearance, she was born two thousand two hundred and nine days ago ... She always remembered how long ago it was. She did not want to count her age in years, after all, she was an absolutely perfect, amazing and unique being. Physically she was over eighteen, and mentally ... Well, she was very old ... Too old

She shook her head to chase away the thoughts crowding in her head. She looked at the city. When the planet and its capital bore the same name, it did not guarantee anything good. Saltmarsh was full of tightly packed buildings. The older ones were made of colonization prefabricated elements, and the newer ones were made of red and black bricks from local clay. The center had a sewage system, but the rest probably had to rely on portable recycling systems or an ordinary septic tank. The city had one fusion power plant to provide power to the residents, but the few vehicles that passed it were powered by alcohol-powered engines powered by a solar cell. The inhabitants had to be motorized,

because the areas on the planet covered with salt deserts and marshes were really large.

She stepped onto the flat roof of the two-story building and looked around wondering where she should go. She didn't know the city, but she hoped so little was happening here that if something unusual happened here, she would probably hear about it. But she was a stranger, and for many reasons chose to remain unnoticed.

"Maybe I'll look at the port first." she said to herself. She saw a bird-rat flying by. She frowned. He annoyed her ...

Two Shirens stood in front of the port building sipping sweet caffeinated drinks.

"Well, three ships in one day. I'm telling you Triktrak. This promises a big change" he drank half a can until his antennae stretched.

"Apparently four, one more damaged. Something can really be on th thin, Shrakat" said the other Shiren and opened the can. "But so what? One ship is damaged anyway, and this pirate captain ... Or maybe he wants to set up a hideout here" said Triktrak.

"There, in the Ravaged Zone, there are more places to hide from Anti." He drank the rest of the can and hiccupped with his windpip.

"But you remember the white demons? No matter how scary a pirate she is, she will not be able to cope with what may be lurking there." said Triktrak. Shrakat flapped his antennae.

"I remember there was one here a few years ago. He was wandering around a bunch of skitermanders, and I'm telling you, he didn't look particularly threatening. Grag was hosting them then. He can be nice if he wants to, but when he smells blood, you'll hit the head with a hammer." he shook his head.

"And only one Grag is like? And do you remember this Vesk from the mountains? You know wh ..." he continued, even without noticing the figure flitting over them.

Randaz straightened, feeling the stiffness in his back. Half a day's work behind him, another half left. But he wasn't complaining for that. Service in the artillery regiment at the front in the war with the Swarm was much worse. He wasn't actually a deserter. He simply got into the wrong transport. But he was content, although he may have lost his honor, or at least a part of it, he nevertheless kept his life and health, including the mental one. Nobody on this planet asked about anything and did not interfere with anything. Just his back. Suddenly he felt watched. He was being watched. He tried to look around, but then heard a voice from behind him.

"Hey reptile. I'm aiming a sniper rifle in your back right now, but if you answer a few of my questions I'll let you go safe and sound, maybe even with all your limbs.

Randaz sighed, it was bad luck he should have expected. Gods don't like cowards and deserters.

"Say what you want." he said resignedly.

"Cheer up . It's a sunny day today, so if you don't try any tricks, I won't really hurt you. Just tell me what ships have recently landed on the planet.

The voice was muffled by some kind of mask, but he could recognize the voice of a young female mammal.

|There weren't many of them, one ship came for flies, but it brought some strange visitors. "One is such a big dandy that he drags a huge mirror behind him. Weird, but no one in their right mind comes here unless they have to. Apparently other damaged ship landed in the desert, but no one knows exactly who it belonged to. There is, of course, the Merciless that belongs to Captain Moonshadow. I see connections there, but what can I know about pirates?"

"Moonshadow, you know what she might be looking for here?" asked the person pointing at his back.

"I have no idea, but everyone says she's done to much to anger Twins, and Anti won't let her go until she stands in chains in front of the Aeon Throne. Though others say he is looking for some great treasure in the Ravaged Zone. Who can tell what the truth is. You will never know truth about pirates ... And apart from her, another ship has landed here ... It has a terribly stupid name ... Something with a sword"

Suddenly he felt a missile of hot plasma flew past his cheek. He almost burned him. *My goddamn tongue*

"Deadly sword of burning fury is a very nice name for a very beautiful ship. Do you know how long it took before we agreed? Three days! And we had a fight four times. So don't offend him here. Or you'll get hit."

He sighed deeply. *What kind of madman is handing out hot-headed kids weapons and ships? And did these kids have to end up on a planet where he was trying to live a quiet life ... On the other hand, who normal would come to Saltmarsh?*

"I am asking forgiveness for offending your wonderful and beautiful ship. Forgive me, miss." he said with a resigned voice "You still have any questions, miss."

"Is Moonshadow on the planet? And if so, where?" She asked, jumping to the ground. She walked past and stood in front of him. By Veska standards, it was tiny. She picked up her goggles and he saw a pair of golden cat eyes with blue spots staring at him. *Damn Pahtras.*

"She would rather not introduce herself to an ordinary foreman like me. You would look for someone from its crew in the port canteen or in Red Water. Some kin of the niece lady is running her."

She stabbed him in the chest with the finger of a strange metal prosthesis.

"I am not litle girl and there is no other creature like me in the entire galaxy, for I am absolutely perfect, amazing and unique!"

He felt a slight tingling sensation every time she stabbed his chest. And she did it on every syllable. Then she jumped into the shadows and disappeared down a side street.
Its time to move out Randez thought.

"I'm telling you, this whole trip is a stupid idea!" Gydwa said to Keart. They were standing behind the harbor canteen, hidden in the shadows. Halfdrowl spat out some red root.

"If the information we got on that ship is true, and we have no reason to say otherwise, we will finally get rich. Treasures of an ancient civilization and the wealth of a fallen empire. As ordinary pirates, we would never have had such a chance." the boatswain explained to large Vesk ...

"We are pirates, not freedom fighters fighting to overthrow the Star Empire? " said Gydwa sarcastically. Kaert waved his hand and bit down another piece of red root.

"We may have been fairly unusual pirates , but you have to admit that under Captain Moonshadow we never felt bad or lacked anything. Unless you're still jealous of Tonado becoming first mate." The half drow said, grinning.

Veska gurgled loudly from deep in her throat.

"I will not let this ball of hair thow me of from the position I have waited for so long!" she looked at the halfdrow "As if I wanted to be able to squeeze him so tightly in my hands until his head explodes." She clenched the imaginary skittermander.

"It's a temporary job anyway. When Reh'zar returns, he will retake his postion. So don't fight for something that will never belong to you anyway." he said, and shook his head disapprovingly.

The second officer looked at him seriously.

"Everyone has as much as they can get." she said slowly with clear undertones ...

Keart eyed her sidelong, clearly unhappy with the direction the conversation was taking.

"You know, this is almost under incitement to mutiny." I will pretend this one time that I didn't hear it. He said slowly reaching for the ice gun at his belt.

"Don't overdo it, I just express my dissatisfaction. We are pirates and we can say whatever we like. And if in fact there are such treasures that he tells us about, I will be the first to beg forgiveness for my lack of faith." Veska bowed excessively.

Keart grimaced but said nothing, just spat a bit of a root.

"They say the Captain is looking for someone here. Someone from where she comes from." The boatswain said. Gydwa snarled

"And to which we're going. I hope that it will not turn out that at the end of the road her husband or her wife and a group of kids are waiting for her."

This time Kaert laughed sincerely.

"You imagine our captain having even one kid. What else? That she is a princess or a queen? Don't be petty .. One thing I'm absolutely sure is that no one misses her, because surely someone would be looking for her ..." said half-drow. Veska, however, did not seem convinced.

"The Ravaged Zone is hard to get to, so it's even harder to get out of there. The locals probably don't even know about the existence of Vescarium, let alone the Pact Worlds or Azlanti. I don't know who we'll find here, but it's probably some random miner or trader who is only more intelligent than Tonada."

"And apparently they have a miner here, I think Shiren, who went to the zone a year ago to earn to pay off alimony or something. He got scared of something there, but I have no idea what. He has fired the crew and sits and drinks." Kaert said thoughtfully

"It's Shiren. They can get scared by a fly trap or a pissed off skittermander." Gydwa laughed wickedly.

"You have an awful lot of prejudice against other species." said Kaert. Veska wanted to say something, but they heard a broken screech. Several black feathers fell beside them.

"Apparently upset some cat." Said the halfdrow.

The Red Water bar was definitely not a den. Rather, he was one of the places where an ordinary passer-by would be afraid to look, although he would most likely be safe there. The key word was most likely. There were never fights here, because the regulars, when they threw themselves into the fight, they kill. They were professionals, former space pirates, war veterans and travelers. Shirkas, as an asteroid miner, was classified rather in the lower regions of the local hierachy,but he was still our guy. He had earned a some reputation on his foray into the Ravaged Zone, though the more mischievous say it was all just the result of his thoughtlessness. It was not true, at least not entirely. The truth was, he was just desperate. His wife and their host demanded the payment of alimony, and he had no intention of ending up behind bars for such stupidity. Or worse, let his ship be scrapped. What could be more terrible for him there? He knew the answer ...

"And then I had got the transmission! There was a unchitinous woman. Her lips and eyes were smiling, but then I saw what was growing out of her head. It was a purple brain-eating octopus. I saw inside her, behind a smile, an immensity of suffering ... This creature devoured her mind, piece by piece, in tiny portions. And I turned out to be such a coward that I didn't react, I just ran away. To this day I see it as soon as I fall asleep. If I found more courage in my heart..." he shook his head, and the two young

shirens who were watching him without much enthusiasm stood up, thanking him for the story.

Well, he was never good at telling a story, and after a year this one had already become somewhat boring He sighed and drank a drink of fermented juice, then went behind the bar to get rid of the excess fluid in his body. He stood in the shadows, and was getting ready to take off his dungarees, but then a figure hissed out of the shadows. He felt a strong blow to his chest, and she grabbed his antenae.

"Hey bug. Answer my questions succinctly, or else I will tear that antennae out and poke your brain out through your windpipe!" unchitinous female said. Two golden cat eyes with blue doth stared at him warningly. A metal hand held his wrist

"Ask, I will answer just don't touch the middle arms." he pleaded.

"Okay, how you can aford drinking for the last year if your trip was going to be so bad." She said. Her eyes smiled grimly.

"I don't know what you're talking about." he said, trying to avoid her eyes. She twisted his antenae.

"I told you not to lie." She growled.

"Okay, okay, just don't hurt me. I'm a simple Shiren, I'm just unlucky. You see, a few years ago some weird guy flew over there with a bunch of Skittermander and some robot. He returned from Vesk III a few weeks ago and was looking for a way back. I told Grag, the local hustler, about everything, and he took him in. I mean, he's trapped and now wants to auction him off. He give me a share." he said with a pleading voice.

The girl jumped away from him and said.

"Don't tell anyone what we talked about, because you know, brains and antenaes" she threatened him with a knife that slipped from the sleeve of her left hand. Then she disappeared in the shadow of one of the buildings.

Shirkas was glad that she didn't press where the money came from, otherwise he would have to tell about a drow woman with a cane ending in the symbol of bat wings…

Eti was walking pleased. She got the lead, alone, without resorting to violence and intimidation. She just spoke politely to a few people and they were answer her.

"Itel do you hear me? I have a lead! I got it myself!" She exclaimed, passing in front of the bar from which the Solarian unexpectedly came out. She seemed ashamed that Eti had met her here

" It's great ... " she said hesitantly, but Eti took her hand and said

" It was actually predictable given my absolutely perfect diplomatic skills." She pouted her chest proudly.

It was two thousand two hundred and ninth day of her life. Sunny day

Entrapted

When he pondered over the last few days how it got to his current situation, he always remembered the words of his Skittermander friend Ablok.

Remember, the galaxy is a dangerous place. You must have eyes in the back of your head. And on the sides of it... And in a few other places... It's actually good if you grow eyes on stalks. Yes, at least four. Then no one will surprise you.

He should have listened. At least metaphorically. Up until now, the universe had seemed like a pretty nice place to him. At least from the time... When he was destroyed. Now he has discovered that the universe has a dark side.

It all started with the fact that he wanted to return to his home. Or at least to a place that resembled him. To his older brother and friends… Especially the one who freed him and gave him a name…

Or maybe it all started with the fact that he wanted to go to the stars ... Actually, he was born among them, in space. Aboard the Velvet Glove. His friend supposed there must be something more beyond the Empire. And of course she was right, as always, though others were skeptical, especially the queen.
Only now was not noot important how it began, but where it was all going. He was in a deep pit dug in the dry land of Saltmarsh. On a rope, they where lowered a bowl of food and a bucket for waste, and another for water. No one has spoken to him since he was placed here. He had no idea what they were going to do with him, but he wasn't worried about himself. The most important thing was what happened to Emily! Didn't they do anything to her?

"Hey Worm" he heard a voice from above. He looked there and saw a person sitting on the edge, his legs dangling.

"I'm not a Worm. I'm a Wrongdak, actually Wrong Hordak. Nice to meet you, but please call me by my name." he said, but he was glad in spirit. Perhaps salvation has just come.

"You're big, white, and you'd be very tasty if you were grilled."

Or maybe it wasn't the rescue he was hoping for.

"What are you going to do with me?" he asked uncertainly. The person he was talking to was dressed in a rather disturbing looking armor. She had a mask and goggles on her face. Instead of a right arm, she had a strange metal prosthesis. He knew such devices were common in the galaxy, but the sight of them always made him sad. Usually his seriously injured brothers were used for spare parts or biological material, though sometimes *He* had other plans.

"I don't think I'm going to eat you because Bina is supposed to bring meat, unless she forgets. You know, I haven't eaten meat for two weeks..." she said, sighed heavily. "Me and my buddies want to get you out of here. Don't worry, just don't tell anyone." she said and disappeared into the shadows.

"But… Emily." he said softly as she disappeared.

Itel paced nervously behind the escarpment behind which they had hidden, waiting for an answer from Eti, who had been silent for almost an hour since she had gone out to scout. She warned that she could turn off her communicator so she wouldn't be distracted. Except she was supposed to be back half an hour ago.

"Hey Itel, listen, I'll draw a plan for you in a moment" behind her came the voice she was waiting for. First she felt relief, then a rush of rage. Eti stood in front of her without a mask and hood,

and then began to draw on the sand with the barrel of a rifle as if nothing had happened.

"Listen, it looks like this..." she started, but the elf yelled at her.

"You didn't think to tell us you were okay!"

"Well, I didn't think about" replied Eti. The Scout looked at her in surprise. There was confusion in her golden eyes with blue dots. Itel loved looking into those beautiful eyes, but right now she was too irritated to think about it.

"Could you think of others? You know we're worried too?" solarian called.

"Excuse me, but would you kindly show a little trust? I am an excellent scout." Eti replied, contorting her face in anger

"Yes of course, because it's always about you!" The elf screamed, spreading her hands.

"Itel, Eti, do you understand that "Hiding" and "Screaming at each other for stupid things" are mutually exclusive?" Alatar said, looking over the interface he had on his hand. He was about to hack into the computer system of Grag's warehouses, which was slow due to the quality of the network here, whichwas deplorable. He was crouched behind the escarpment, trying to remain invisible. Lilka stood with her knees on the escarpment and looked through the binoculars if anyone was approaching.

Itel took a deep breath to calm herself down. She closed her eyes and when she opened them she said.

"Okay, Eti, please tell us what you found out."

Eti almost smiled. She never did, not out of joy. But Itel was sure she would look beautiful then.
"There are six guards, but only two look dangerous. They are armed with electric rifles. The rest have ordinary clubs, none have

decent armor. These two always walk side by side and look like siblings, but I'm not sure because they're Shirrens, and I can't quite figure out how they're related. The others walk chaotically as they please. They used to have a mustelid guard animal, but they said it was bitten by a snakebird." she said, and her hand went to the sack where she had hidden the carcass of some birdie she had hunted in the meantime. Eti couldn't control her instincts sometimes.

"It's a good thing they didn't have a dog there, otherwise it would have been an impregnable fortress" Alatar muttered.

"Oh, I think your mouth misses my shoe." Eti replied putting her cat ears on herself.

"Are there any treasures?"Lilka asked, changing the subject, much to Itel's relief, who didn't want another argument, this time between Eti and Alatar about "Cat stuff".
The Scout winced.

"It's a goods depot for farmers and nomads. There are parts for vehicles, water filters, fertilizer, seeds, some simple robots and elecronic. Our target is hidden in a beer warehouse, just sitting in a dug pit between the barrels. Looks like the drow, orc, and the bat had a very intoxicating night, but he talks our way."

Itel felt like she was about to punch someone.

"Have you talked to him? Who allowed you to do this?" she snapped at Eti. The sniper looked at her in surprise. Sometimes she was so sweetly innocent… Or innocently insensitive.

"After all, no one forbade me, and what is not forbidden is allowed. It's called Wormdak." she replied, scratching behind the cat's ear

"Is that his name, or did you call him that?" Alatar asked suspiciously.

"I named him. He says his name is Wrongdak or Wrong Hordak..." There was silence for a moment.

"It must have been a very complex family situation." Alatar said.

"It's quite big, but also strong, so it might come in handy to carry heavy stuff." Eti said contentedly. "They have two more cameras and a few electronic gates, so Alatar can break in there?"

"I'm doing it right now." said the dragonkin from over the interface

"Only two armed guards... Do you think you could take them down without anyone noticing?" asked the solarian. Eti looked at her carefully.

"I think so. But I'd rather" said the sniper. Eti could be aggressive and was created with no inhibitions against harming others, but she didn't like taking lives. The few times she did this, she was very upset during rainy days. Itel understood her, but she had lost her scruples during the swarm's invasion of Kesler. But after all, Igzar had told her to protect the others... Didn't that also include protecting from her? Before what the Swarm was doing to her?

"All right, Eti, we'll try not to leave any dead bodies behind. Maybe it will be better that way, because we won't make more enemies" she said in a conciliatory tone. The ranger walked over to the elf and placed a metal hand on her shoulder. Although Itel didn't like the touch of the archaeotechnical hand, she felt a shiver run through her body anyway.

"Thanks Itel, I'll do what I can. You know I'm the best." - Eti said. „You are" thought Itel.

It wasn't the best plan, but it was the only one he had. He wasn't sure if he could rely on that strange person's help. There was no time to lose. Emily's life was in danger!

So he took the spoon and continued digging, trying not to think how hopeless his situation was. Then he heard the blast of an energy weapon. Instinctively, he cowered, not like a civilian, but like the soldier he was made for. There were screams of the wounded, and battle cries. He heard the voice of this strange person, as well as several other people. He found himself in the heat of battle again, but this time he was absolutely defenseless…

Not. He looked at what he had in his hand. *He had a spoon!*

After a while, however, the gunshots stopped and there was a moaning silence.
He was saved!

"It's good to tie them up and bandage the badly wounded one ... And the one without an arm too. Lilka, put her in the bucket

He wasn't sure if he wanted to be saved by these people...

This strange person sat on the edge and started swinging her legs. After a while, a winged lizard and two girls appeared next to her. One with pointed ears and green hair and the other a redhead with a large ax in her hands. They looked as menacing as a squad of vesk.

"Hey Wormdak, I told you we'd come to free you," she said with satisfaction in her voice.

"I am Wrong Hordak, but you can call me Wrongdak"

"Hi, Wormdak… Wrongdak… Wrong Hordak… I'm Lilka."said the redhead

"And I am Alatar" said the Lizard, and showed on the Datapad's display *Ignore that Eti is calling you names.*

"And I am Itel, someone will throw him a rope, because we are in a bit of a hurry?"

The masked girl tossed him a long rope attached to something above, and he climbed it. A few Shirren lay on the ground, all injured, two quite seriously, but they were given basic medical care ... Although someone should have to take care of them eventually. He knew the basics of first aid and could even perform simple surgeries on himself, but *He* preferred to replace his brothers with new ones rather than heal them.

"All right, Wormdak, follow us and don't think, because thinking hurts. Sometimes very literally - said the girl with the metal hand, crouching on the barrel. He saw that she had a tail that twitched nervously. He met several Pahtras on Vesk III, though he didn't befriend any of them. Then the warehouse doors swung open and the Duergar Grag stood there, trapping him there.

"Hey, what are you going to do with my commodity? You can't afford to buy it. You can't even imagine what kind of people are interested in buying this creature." said Grag, baring his metal teeth. Beneath his cloak he had heavy armor clearly visible, and in his hands he held a two-handed hammer, on which the discharges ran. A large insectoid stood next to him.

"But they didn't take anything from you. All barrels are whole." he said, completely not understanding what the trader meant.

"But you are my most valuable commodity. You know how much certain people will pay for a living White Demon. I wish I understood what you were worth the first time, I would have sold you long ago and paid off my debts.

He los his togue. How he dare do that to someone!

"But... that's not allowed. You can't sell someone. Persons are not things" He said *I don't want to be owned again!*

"Oh White Demon, believe me, the strong can do with the weak…" he jumped when the pahtra fired a rifle at him. The insectoid pulled out a shotgun and fired at the masked one

himself. However, she dodged and landed on the wall, to which she stuck her shoes. Beer began to pour out of the keg.

"Okay, let's do it." said the green-haired girl and summoned the silver blade.

"For The Horde!" The redhead screamed, drawing her ax.

No! No! No! he cried in his mind.

Itel knew this was how it would end. She hated it when even simple plans had to fall apart anyway, so she had to improvise. Holding her blade, she summoned dark matter and began to tune into the gravitational forces that held the world together. She jumped towards the Duergar, trying to flank him while furious Lilka attacked with a flaming axe. She hit the hammer's handle with the blade. Then Itel attacked him from the side, trying to stab him in the shoulder with the moonblade, but Grag growled and pushed Lilka away and hit the Elf in the face with an armored shoulder-plate. It hurt, but it would have been worse if she hadn't been protected by dark matter. During this time, Alatar cast a spell on Trox that made him lose his knowledge of how to operate his weapons. Eti jumped to the ground, then drew her laspistol and shot the insectoids in the side, but his armor held out. Grag swung his hammer, forcing the warriors to retreat, but at the same time he dodged as Alatar fired his rifle at Trox, who fired several times indiscriminately, no longer understanding how his weapon worked. Taking the opportunity when the Duergar dodged, Lilka hit the epaulette, which broke, but Grag tripped her with the handle of his hammer. He turned and swung at Eti, who was aiming for his back. The ranger blocked the blow with a metal hand. There was a bang as the ancient prosthesis absorbed some of the Energy. Iteel then felt she was fully attuned to the Graviton, so she summoned a gravity ball that pulled Grag backwards, knocking him over. The elf jumped and drove the moon blade into the trader's shoulder. He screamed, as did Trox, who was shot simultaneously by dragonkin and Eti. Lilka stood up and put the

ax to Grag's neck. Then a spoon thrown by the prisoner hit his face.

"Give up!" the Solarian woman said, and twisted the blade in the Duergar's wound. Troks writhed in pain, both opponents released their weapons.

"Do you know who was going to buy it? Lord Admiral Antares. You know who is he scum from Kesler? I am from Atrax and I remember how many of you were saved by his ships. You don't know who you're displease" growled Grag.

"That's the last name you should be referring to." Itel thought. Eti straightened her tail anxiously clenching her fingers on the gun. Itel felt only overwhelming fury. She drew the knife Igzar had given her, then plunged it into Duergar's knee.

"Igzar sends his regards to the Lord Admiral." she said and twisted the blade. She stood up and, ignoring Grag's screams, looked at the others. Everyone was fine, although Eti was rubbing her hand behind the elbow, where her metal arm ended. The prisoner tended to the wounded shiren, stealing a frightened look at them. At first she thought it was a rare slave collector or someone in the intelligence service who wanted to get it, but Antares? Why was he interested in such creatures and in the Ravaged Zone in general.

Lilka was wiping her forehead when the prisoner, whose name was probably Wrongdak, approached her and, putting his hands on her shoulders, said in a serious voice.
"Listen. Horde doesn't exist. He... Prime is dead and the Horde is gone. Are you free!"

"He wants to die?" Itel thought, Tears appeared in Lilka's eyes and her lips began to twitch. She grabbed the ax and screamed "The Horde will exist as long as there is at least one orc alive!" The redhead exclaimed and swung. The Wrongdak jumped back and started to run.

"Alatar, calm her down" the elf ordered. Dragonkin ran to the enraged warrior.

"What now?" asked Eti, standing next to Itel. There was concern in her voice.

"Nothing special. We don't tell Bina because she'll be back again. Lord Antares doesn't know about us, and with any luck he won't." the solarian said, trying not to glance at the Duergar writhing in pain. *I didn't need to show off. Now it would be best if we finished him off.*

Wrongdak finally climbed onto the barrel, and the dragonkin calmed Lilka down.

"He must have meant some completely different evil horde, didn't he?" Alatar asked the ex-prisoner in a meaningful tone.

"Very evil, made of ones like me ..."said Wrongdak. Lilka calmed down and sheathed the ax.

"I see. A real horde of orcs consists of countless hosts of honorable warriors who fight for good and justice". Lilka explained to him with absolute seriousness.

"But you're…" he wanted to say, but Dragonkin showed him a datapad with the inscription *Lilka is an orc, it's an indisputable fact.*

He descended slowly, clearly being careful not to provoke another attack of aggression.

"What are we supposed to do with him?" Itel asked. Eti shrugged.

"In exchange for a ride home, he will clean, carry heavy things and clean toilets." replied the scout.

"And what will we feed him?" the solarian asked, expecting what answer she would hear.

"Vescarian rations, of course" Eti exclaimed happily. Itel looked at her grimly for a moment.

"That's mean even for you." she finally said.

Meanwhile, the prisoner came up to them and spoke earnestly.

"I have to ask for help. My friend Emily has also been imprisoned and needs to be rescued!"

"Is Emily pretty?" Eti asked with interest.

"Oh, she's beautiful!" cried Wrongdak.

"We're in!" Eti and Alatar shouted simultaneously.

Itel looked at the scout. *Did you have to do that?* she thought. Then she walked over to the dueergar and kicked him in the wounded shoulder.

"Where is the one who accompanied the prisoner?"

Grag laughed despite the pain.

- She went to the junkyard.

She was unlucky. the Solarian sighed.

Hellknight

Asindesa di Vir throughout her life knew mainly war, in all its aspects. She was actually born in the war. Her name used to be Asindesa Cartak, but that was all she remembered from her former life. For thirty-five years she had believed it was the Dominion of Black atacked her homeplanet, until recently she had learned the truth, but it had not changed anything in her life. Enemies might have different names, but knowing how to defeat them was all that mattered. Empires will fall and rise, and adversaries will put on new masks, and the order of the eclipse will continue to serve its cause as always. There were only two exceptions. Servants of Darkness Among the Stars and a Hunger That Can't Be Satiated. The former lasted from the beginning of the universe, the latter may lead to its destruction. That's why the Order had to face this threat... And now a new threat has arisen and the lictor, her adoptive father, have sent her to deal with it, and to hell, she will fulfill this task.

She was going to her second meeting with Lord Admiral Antares wearing the plate armor of a hellknight. The armor of the Order of Eclipse was quite harmless looking, covered only by two spikes on the shoulders. Of all the hellknights orders, the Order of Eclipse was considered the most heroic because its opponents were those who were a threat to the existence of entire civilizations. In the past, they usually fought the servants of the Old Ones or the Dominion of Black, and often made enemies of those they protected. But since the Swarm invasion, they have become the protectors of the galaxy. Asindesa has even participated in several photo shoots to encourage the Galactic public opnion to unite in the fight against a common enemy. In truth, she hated it, though she understood how important it was to the success of the entire War. She was aware that she was well suited to represent the allied forces. Tall, with a pretty face not even disfigurd by an acid scar, with long red-gold hair. She was forty years old, but she knew that with modern medicine, she would face at least twice as

many years of fighting and bloodshed, if she did not die on the battlefield, as most of the knights of the order would do

The loud footsteps of three pairs of armored boots echoed through the brightly lit corridors. At her flanks were two other knights who were her retinue and protection, though she doubted Antares would be ready to attack her openly. On the left was Camalia Sendes, an Aasimar with white hair and a cheerful smile, who was the direct opposite of what people expected from hell knights. She was beautiful, though she did not share the Lady of Blades' preferences. She was a devout follower of Iomadae, which also surprised many who expected the HellKnights to fanatical devotion to Asmodeus. On the right was Grimbern, a black-haired man, a man who had been Asindesa's protégé and trained by her to be her successor. They were the most loyal of her subjects, and they knew the secret of her sword.

She looked at the hilt protruding from the new scabbard. She didn't know what the weapon actually was, but she had been told what it was called. "E

nd of Eternity - Blade of Vengeance". She shivered, though she was a warrior unafraid to face the innumerable hosts of the Swarm. She didn't know why she had been chosen to wield this weapon, but she felt that she could not oppose this mission. It had to do with the White Demons. The ones who attacked Minitar and turned her into a hellknight.

The Lord Admiral was waiting for her on the bridge of his flagship. Commander Reese and Lady Ka were also here. The Commander bowed to her politely, if a little stiffly.
"We are glad to see you, Ansidesa Di Vir, Lady of the Blades of the Order of the Eclipse" he said in a serious but genuinely polite tone.

"So the most unsmiling of the knights has arrived. Indeed, it is a great honor for us." said Lady Ka with undisguised sneer, bowing almost halfway down.

Lord Admiral Anatares turned away from the holographic star chart.

"It's good to see you, Asindesa." he said, bowing politely but without exaggeration, like a king greeting an envoy from a foreign country. Actually, there was nothing unusual about it. Before he became a mercenary, he was a ruler.

"Why specifically have you summoned me here, Lord Admiral?" she asked in a hard voice, not taking her eyes off the expedition commander.

"Ah, those hellknights, they are discussing as if they were charging into fortified positions." said Lady Ka sneeringly. The Lord Admiral ignored his Left Hand, but did not rebuke it either, which eloquently showed how the relations in the expedition command look like. Only the commander gave the masked woman a contemptuous look.

"I want to talk to you about Lady Caly Grayskull" he asked in a strong and resonant voice. She supposed he'd practiced its sound for a long time, especially after being shot. She wasn't sure if it was vanity or perfectionism, probably both.

"And about my time at Castle Grayskull." she asked in a grim voice. Well, she should have assumed someone like Antares would find out. *I haven't done anything wrong, so why am I nervous?*

"Pre-emptive strike, hmm smart... However, my job is to gather intel on potential enemies... and allies which is basically the same thing." The visible part of Lady Ka's mouth twisted into an even more sneering smile than usual.

"Lady Cala and her maps are one of the pillars of this expedition, so as its commander it is my duty to know how much we can relly on her." He looked questioningly at her entourage. They instinctively stepped back, but she signaled them to stay. The Lord Admiral did not recall his guardsmen, the famous Void Orphans, so neither should she recall hers.

"I have not met the young Lady in person. My ship was damaged, and it took most of my time to arrange repairs in Carurystal, where no one is ever in a hurry. I only spoke to Miss Daisy. Her…" she tried to remember what her official position was.

"For all I know, she's probably something like her right hand , Lady of Blades." Commander Reese interjected. Lady Ka just snorted softly.

"Second in Command maybe right away? Seriously, this girl lets her own governess run her fortune?" said the head of Antares's intelligence service.

Asindesa pursed her lips.
"Miss Daisy is a multi-talented person and a powerful sorceress." she said briskly, and then realized she had fallen into a trap set by a woman with a mask on the right half of her face.

"Yes, we know that, and that she brought her from the Pact Worlds on her journey five years ago... I guess the girl wanted to celebrate her coming of age in this way... Lady Daisy is definitely not from the Pact Worlds.

The Hellknight shrugged.
"Like most of the people here. I was born on Minitar, Lord Admiral is from Tarak, Commander Reese is from Amran and you Lady Ka are from Atrax, I can recognize that accent very well" said Lady of Blades, feeling joy at seeing Lady Ka's smile fade.

"What I'm saying is that no one knows exactly where she comes from, which is understandably uncomfortable for those of our position, but truth be told, we don't care much about her. We want to know how much truth Lady Cala tells, because we know that all intelligent people lie." said Lady Ka slowly and, for her, exceptionally gently.

"I'm not lying…" She bit her tongue as she realized she get into trap.

"Undoubtedly…" Lady Ka continued her taunt, but the Lord Admiral motioned for her to be quiet.

"There's no point in teasing each other like children. Please tell me one thing. Is Lady Cala someone who might have maps from thousands of years ago?" asked the Lord Admiral. His living eye glowed a cold blue. Cybernetic lens glowed red. *How strange it was to talk to someone with such different eyes?* She thought for a moment.

"Castle Grayskull was built thousands of years ago, and in its vaults... They stretch across the entire peninsula and may contain treasures from before the last wave of colonization, so these maps may..."As she spoke, she saw an image on the monitor behind the Lord Admiral that she knew from information she was provided by Liktor Janos Di Vir. The face of one of the White Demons, quite unusual, wearing a strangely colored shirt and colored hair, but still one of the creatures that attacked Minitar...

"Yes?" Antares asked, raising one eyebrow.

"These maps may be real." she said. The image was gone, she wasn't even sure if it wasn't all just a phantasm.

"Well, apparently that will have to suffice. You can leave, I have no more questions." replied the Lord Admiral.

She bowed politely and was already turning away from the expedition leader when he asked her.

" I'm sorry I forgot to ask. I hope your wound, the one you take on Carurystal, has healed properly by now?"

She resisted the instinctive urge to reach for her shoulder. She could almost see a sneer spread across Lady Ka's face.

"Almost completely. So is your gunshot wound." she smiled and left.

They did not discuss the meeting until they were aboard her cruiser Necessary Measures.

|"It went reasonably well." Camalia said.

"It went very badly, he found out a lot about us without revealing anything he didn't want to reveal himself." said the hellknight.

"You're a terrible pessimist, and you see conspiracies everywhere." said the follower of Iomadae

"I am the Lady of Blades, that is my duty." Asindesa said.

They walked in silence for a while.

"But you have to admit, Commander Reese is sweet." Aasimar said.

"You know he's…" Grimbern interjects
- I know, but I like him anyway. Asia, and you like Lady Ka?

The Lady of Blades rolled her eyes.

"Really, I don't want sleep with every woman I meet, I'm very picky. Besides, going to bed with her is like going to bed with a scorpion."

"This sword, are you sure it's not cursed.?" Grimbern asked

"It's not even fully magical, and something tells me it's very important?" Asindesa said quietly.

"And these inscriptions? You guess who might have made them and what they mean.?

Only she saw them. She managed to trace them and enter them into the database, she didn't learn much.

"They are made in the language of the First Ones, who built the cities of Aballon and created the Anacities. But no one can

translate them. But the First Ones are no more." she said, remembering the words spoken to her.

This is End of Eternity. Vengeance Blade. Take them, for the day of vengeance draws near. Punishment Day

Too bad you didn't see him. Maybe you could give me some advice thought the Hellknight

The First of The Thousand

Lady Ka sneered as she saw Asindesa come out of the bridge.

"Manipulating Hellknights is like kicking a puppy. A lot of joy, but no satisfaction." she giggled.

Antares looked at her askance.

"I hope we won't hurt ourselves with this ruse." he said thoughtfully, touching the lens of his cybernetic eye.

Lady Ka waved her hand.

"By no means. What can they prove to us? That we were trying to obtain one of the White Demons, creatures we might be fighting. Also, as commander, you don’t have a duty to share confidential intelligence with your subordinates. And we've learned that the Order of the Eclipse, and perhaps all the other orders, are hiding the truth about the Ravaged Zone from the people of the Galaxy." she laughed " We only made sure that the world knew the truth."

The commander Reese winced as he listened to her argument.

"It is not right to manipulate allies, especially when the whole galaxy depends on us."

The intelligence officer gave him a contemptuous look.

If they rely on us, they'll be surprised Lady Ka thought with amusement.

The heavy cruiser Invictus may not have been the most powerful ship in the fleet, but of all, it held all the important secrets Antares possessed... and all its dark deeds. “As he used to say, keep evil out of your home. Invite them to your summerhouse." She had to admit that her superior had an extraordinary talent for aphorisms.

He was also a man who valued science. She was about to go to one of the greatest minds in the galaxy. Literally and figuratively. She had served Antares for five years, ever since Igzar slew her predecessor, Testimonez. Personally, she thought she was doing an excellent job as an intelligence officer. Even she herself was sometimes surprised by her talent for solving problems of a delicate… or dark nature. But Lady Sorrowflame had served House Antares for two hundred years. And Lady Ka knew very well that she was much, much older…
The corridors of the cruiser were shrouded in darkness. All the lights were dimmed. All important prisoners were kept here, so it was necessary to create a suitable atmosphere. The Lord Admiral liked to slowly soften the prisoners, to mold them for months, so that they would finally understand their mistake and do the will of Antares of their own free will. Lady Ka was not patient enough, so she preferred harsher methods. After all, everyone was entitled to a little pleasure, right?
There was only one prisoner on the ship at the moment, but he was the most special of them all. Antares' favorite for over thirty years, whom only he could interrogate. He held ordinary prisoners on transport ships with absolute respect for all international conventions. Prisoners are not taken to die of hunger or disease. Of course, sometimes it was enough just not to take prisoners. "Orders not given, crimes not done."
By the smell she knew she was approaching Lady Sorrowflame's workshop. The smell of a corpse, necromantic ingredients, formalin and liquorice created a unique blend that became the hallmark of the ancient Necrotechnician. The great room was even darker than the corridors, shrouded in red light, full of strange machines and body fragments. Lady Sorrowflame was sensitive to light, and many relics stored here would be destroyed instantly after short exposure. The lady of the place has stood by the big metal brother and screwed the metal plates to the corpse of the three-and-a-half-foot humanoid. Lady Ka whistled in admiration.
- Is it amazing that you build each of the Dread Walker yourself! - she said, looking at the object of research of the red-haired woman. She stopped her work, turned to the head of intelligence and took off her gloves.

- If you want your position to be unwavering, you must be irreplaceable. And to be irreplaceable, you must not let anyone in on your secrets.
The Necrotechnician was a very attractive woman. Tall with alabaster skin and fiery hair. Of the entire command, she was the only one to establish closer relations with her. Even very close. Well, the Lord Admiral was quite handsome, and even if he wasn't, she would have gone to bed with him just to hurt Reese, but her overlord didn't like to mix work with pleasure. Of course, the commander did not take it into account for more or less obvious reasons. But Lady Sorrowflame was a woman both hot as flame and cold as folk. If anyone could be said to like him, it's an ancient necromancer.
-And how's the search for the artifact going? – Said the necrotechnician looking at the intelligence officer
Lady Ka winced.
- I have invested considerable resources in finding this gadget, but still no lead, - she said a little embarrassed.
- It's such a shame. You can't even imagine how important it can be! - Sorrowflame said sharply. Her eyes sparkled gold. But the head of intelligence rolled her only visible eye.
- You don't think I'm going to find that relic? - If I find him, I'll find my little sister and her little monster. And believe me, there's nothing I want more than these two. But the old leech defends them. she said, but then she changed her mind. - Sorry about the leech. - She preferred not to make an enemy of a creature of such great personal power.
- As we talk about the little monsters. I analyzed your father's papers. There was indeed a prototype - the necrotechnician said, accepting the apology - But Jantar sold it to Nayrlathetop's cultists.
- Oh, I'm so sad. It's just my heart bleeds. Ms. Ka murmured with undisguised satisfaction.
- Don't don’t understimate it. After all, you too should rot in the depths of the Atrax caves.- Lady Sorrowflame smiled.
- Don't compare me to some bioengineering freak. I am K-nation number 4886. Supreme Queen Ka. The First of a Thousand.

This is the thirteenth chapter of this story, so I decided to leave comments in which I will mention the curiosities related to this fic. Mrs. Ka's thread was created by accident during an RPG session when players killed one npc, so he had to come back in a different version.
Lady Sorrow is a canon character from Golarion

"The HellKnights have only temporary allies, for they are devoted only to their cause and only it matters to them." the Lord Admiral replied to the commander.

She respected her superior for being able to use the truth as a weapon.

"I understand, sir, but the Lady of Blades... She seems to be an honorable warrior." Reese said carefully.

If you weren't so good at commanding people, I would have thrown you out of the airlock a long time ago for stupidity.: Lady Ka watched at the Commander with the contepmt.

-

"Honor is valuable in peacetime, but in war it can easily lead to unimaginable tragedies." the Lord Admiral said seriously.

The commander nodded. Antares turned to his inteligence oficer.

"Do you think they know anything about the Horde that we don't?" he asked thoughtfully.

"No one knows more than us, except perhaps our toothy friend." said the woman in the half-mask.

"Remember that the galaxy is immeasurable. The so-called Prime Empire was vast and could affect many worlds. During those few years, many may have left its borders without even having Dift Drive and access to planar travel. And others could go there" Antares said slowly, rubbing his face where he had been shot. Lady Ka always wondered if he was aware that he was doing this.

"We still do not know what exactly annihilated the Lord of the Horde and whether he poses a threat to our fleet." he added after a moment.

"Sir, our forces are made up of veterans hardened in the Swarm War. We have five capital ships at our disposal. There's very little we can't handle. said Commander Reese with feverish enthusiasm. The Lord Admiral smiled at his words, but replied.

"That's a lot for a mercenary, but on a galaxy scale... The Horde had forces far greater than ours."

"But Prime is dead and his subjects... you know Lord Admira!" said Commander Reese uncertainly, staring at his commander.

"That's the problem, our dear litle commander." Ka walked over to Rees and took him under the chin. "That's pretty much all we know, which means we don't know anything about his fall."

Antares gave her a warning look. She knew he had a fondness for his former adjutant, and besides, Reese was an effective and well-liked officer. Too bad he was a sanctimonious moron by the way.

"That's why I want this deal to go through." He turned the image back on the monitor. The clone they saw was quite different from the ones they knew. He had colorful hair and light blue eyes. He was wearing a shirt a bit too big for him, one of the kind the Skittermander for Vescs could come up with.

"It gives us first-hand information, without relyng on the successes of our research team and Lady Caly." He looked at Lady Ka meaningfully. She bowed to him almost mockingly.

" I'll try to buy it, but I can't promise anything. As far as I know, there will be three buyers at the auction, including at least one with assets equal to what we have."

"Do you suspect who it could be?" asked hers commander, clearly troubled. He was very rich, after all, so few could rival him.

"Veskarium or Azlanti, maybe Aspis. But I suspect the Azlanti because they have the most to gain, and they did not participate in organizing this expedition. The auctioneer has the protection of the Drejs, a local gang, but that's no problem for us. The dude is from Atrax, so for one word from the First of a Thousand will be on his knees begging for mercy" She laughed with sadistic amusement. Antares, however, did not take his eyes off her.

"You'd better succeed..." He said seriously, but she answered him with an indulgent smile.

"Oh, my good Lord Admiral. Don't expect me to be one of those servants who is always eager to assure their master that all will be well, and then cower in fear when it all falls apart. I wasn't like that for Jantar, I won't be like that for you, that's not why you keep me here."

The Lord Admiral almost smiled. He didn't do that often, and usually it didn't bode well, but she knew him well enough to know she was safe. Whatever can be said, Antares was not one to punish his subjects for harsh words and legitimate criticism. Especially for honesty. Of course, within reason.

"Fly to Invictus, Lady Sorrowflame wants to talk to you." said the Lord Admiral. She saluted him to the temple hidden behind the mask.

"Aye Aye Admiral!" she said, and went to get the documents Sorroowflame probably needed.

After talking to the dork knight and listening to Reese, it's worth spending some time with someone normal. Necrotechnics will do just fine. She struggled to hold back a burst of laughter.

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"Is it amazing that you build each of the Dread Walker yourself!" she said, looking at the object of research of the red-haired woman. She stopped her work, turned to the head of intelligence and took off her gloves.

"If you want your position to be unwavering, you must be irreplaceable. And to be irreplaceable, you must not let anyone in on your secrets."

The Necrotechnician was a very attractive woman. Tall with alabaster skin and fiery hair. Of the entire command, she was the only one to establish closer relations with her. Even very close. Well, the Lord Admiral was quite handsome, and even if he wasn't, she would have gone to bed with him just to hurt Reese, but her overlord didn't like to mix work with pleasure. Of course, the commander did not take it into account for more or less obvious reasons. But Lady Sorrowflame was a woman both hot as flame and cold as folk. If anyone could be said to like him, it's an ancient necromancer.

"And how's the search for the artifact going?" said the necrotechnician looking at the intelligence officer

Lady Ka winced.

"I have invested considerable resources in finding this gadget, but still no lead" she said a little embarrassed.

"It's such a shame. You can't even imagine how important it can be!" Sorrowflame said sharply. Her eyes sparkled gold. But the head of intelligence rolled her only visible eye.

"You don't think I'm going to find that relic?" If I find him, I'll find my little sister and her little monster. And believe me, there's nothing I want more than these two. But the old leech defends them. she said, but then she changed her mind. "Sorry about the leech." She preferred not to make an enemy of a creature of such great personal power.

"As we talk about the little monsters. I analyzed your Father's papers. There was indeed a prototype." the necrotechnician said, accepting the apology "But Jantar sold it to Nayrlathetop's cultists."

"Oh, I'm so sad. It's just my heart bleeds. Lady. Ka murmured with undisguised satisfaction.

- Don't don’t understimate it. After all, you too should rot in the depths of the Atrax caves." Lady Sorrowflame smiled.

"Don't compare me to some bioengineering freak. I am K-nation number 4886. Supreme Queen Ka. The First of a Thousand!"

This is the thirteenth chapter of this story, so I decided to leave comments in which I will mention the curiosities related to this fic.

Mrs. Ka's thread was created by accident during an RPG session when players killed one npc, so he had to come back in a different version.

Lady Sorrow is a canon character from Golarion

Brightmoon ghosts

Brightmoon lost a spare bedroom and gained an Archives. Officially, the Fright Zone Document Depot, but it was actually a lumber-room where documents that no one cared about were stored.

Beyond her.

She knelt by a pile of folders and flicked through them nervously, while the Melog paced around as annoyed as she was. She was looking for… She didn't know what. Mostly something about Adora and… about herself.

She asked Scorpia to provide all the documents regarding the cadets and Scorpia complied to her ask and sent her six skimmers loaded with briefcases. And she apologized anyway that some of the documents had been burned during her *argument* with Hordak. But what was important survived… So for the last few weeks she spent all her free time rummaging through the papers. She was looking for answers, though she didn't know what questions she should ask.

It all started with a question about customary medical examinations. Though in the old days all cadets routinely went through them, Adora would not agree to them now. She was afraid of what other dark secrets her origins might hold. She understood her. Her fiancée's legacy held secrets whose discovery nearly led to the annihilation of their home, as well as many other planets. She did not know what else they could have done to Adora. She however submitted to the tests with a bit of amusement, because what could they discover that she herself would not have known for a long time. And here she was surprised, and she hated being surprised.

Genetic testing showed no relation to the other feline humans found on Etheria, and moreover, it bore traces of genetic manipulation at an extremely advanced level. When she heard from Entrapta *Isn't it fascinating?* she felt her vein was about to burst. In the past, she probably would have gone to destroy something or take it out on someone. Now, however, after ten minutes of breathing exercises, she managed to calm down. She asked Entrapta to gently ask Hordak if he didn't accidentally create her as he was trying to create a new body for himself. She received a response, accurately quoted by the purple-haired woman, that he would never have created her by accident or on purpose. She believed him. He's only managed to create something alive once, and that was imp.

In fact, it shouldn't surprise her. She was fitter, faster, and smarter than most beings she knew. She had claws that could cut metal. and… *And He considered me as his host. He who for millennia inhabited only identical clones.* And that was what terrified her. At first she thought it was because he sensed the evil in her, and then she just tried to forget everything. However, after research, she decided that she needed to look for answers. To calm her anxiety, she decided to find out as much as possible about her background, and there was no better way than to go through the records of the cadet school.

She should have been aware of level the bureaucracy of the Horde. She was in charge of her for several months and everything worked out. Somehow. Some of the responsibilities she simply left to Scorpia or a host of nameless officials, and by the end it all fell apart anyway. She didn't care, in fact she absolutely didn't care about anything by then, and if the war had gone on any longer, the whole machine would have fallen apart... just like her.

She should admire the perfection of the Shadow Weaver system. Everything was designed so that in the end every key regulation had to be approved by the second-in-command. This made it really hard to remove her. Twice it was attempted, of course, in much less spectacular fashion than she did, and each time those

who tried to replace her met with terrible punishmentMany saw Shadow Weaver as a powerful sorcerer, a ruthless schemer, a skilled commander, or even a great teacher, but few realized her immense talent for management. She had no idea where she acquired this skill. All that was known in Mystacor was that she came from the Isles of Sorrow, an archipelago somewhere on the equator. It is said that the rulers of that place repeatedly demanded the expulsion of their fugitive citizen, but the authorities of the sorcerers' guild always refused, saying that it was not lawful to banish someone who only sought safe haven. When she found out about it, she couldn't stop laughing, laughing through her tears.

Now she had to deal with the legacy of Hordak's Right Hand. She was a little uneasy to see that absolutely every aspect of their lives had been documented. Every disease, every quarrel and who likes whom. They knew all their advantages and disadvantages, their height and weight. Their potential. To her surprise, Cobalt gave her very good grades and spoke highly of her, so she felt a bit of sympathy for her former trainer. It is a pity that he was temporarily unavailable, because he was sitting in Drill together with Lonnie and the Rest.

Of course, Shadow Weaver did not fail to record every punishment that was meted out to the cadets. Both these official or private. And she always found a logical-sounding justification. She wondered how much the sorcerer believed in what she wrote, and how much she wanted to justify her cruelty to herself? There was something painfully fascinating about her absolute meticulousness in recording everything she had done to them. Her fines file was obviously the thickest, though she was surprised to find that several people had almost caught up with her for fines, which weren't that bad after all. Such a Scarlet regularly got extra guard duty or toilet cleaning. She didn't know her very well, she must have deserted and holed up somewhere in the crimson wasteland. But as for the punishments privately administered by Shadow Weaver… She remembered every single one that had happened to her. It was hard… Once upon a time, she probably would have gone into a rage and done something terrible or self-destructive,

but now she had Adora by her side. She could cry in her fiancée's arms with Melog hugged at her legs.

She didn't find much about her origins. Too seldom did she take damage, much more often she caused it herself. All the doctors, however, were amazed at the efficiency of her body. They claimed that they had met only one equally capable person, namely Adora. She knew it perfectly well. There was only one document that surprised her, her genetic research done right after Adora found her in that tiny cardboard box. Dr. Moors, a person who was then involved in genetic research of the inhabitants of the Fright Zone. He found that her genome showed signs of hybridization, primarily human and another creature he couldn't recognize. In addition, several more genes were added, including a sequence he described as "Remarkable." He concluded the study with the statement "Chimera or Mutant, further research needed." However, they were never made. Soon after, he was transferred to a remote outpost by Shadow Weaver. Of course, she didn't do it for her. She guessed that the doctor must have been too interested in Adora, so he had to disappear. He was lucky anyway he wasn't sent to Beast Island, or some terrible accident didn't happen to him.

There wasn't much else to be found in the medical reports about her, nothing significant anyway. She found out she had a mole on her right buttock (Adora confirmed) or when she was losing every milk tooth. Still, it was better than she found about her fiancée. All medical reports and test results are gone. She was absolutely sure Shadow Weaver was responsible. If anyone found out who Adora really was… She wasn't sure Hordak would be able to kill a child in cold blood, but it would certainly weaken the sorcerer's position. She only wondered if she hid all the files in her fabled secret archive, where she was supposed to hide her dark secrets. No one had ever seen it and perhaps it was just a myth. She should talk to Hordak, he knew more about Shadow Weaver than anyone else, but she hadn't spoken to her former master in person in years and wished she will never do.

In fact, she should be glad she has a secret past like Adora. And that they have something else in common. After all, it didn't change anything in her ... their life? Perhaps she should do as her fiancée advised her and burn it all down. She was looking for useless answers here only because she was nervous before the wedding. But… H*e was considering me as his next host… Out of the billions of beings he encountered, he chose me. Not Adora, who is one of the First ones and She-ra, but her. Why?* She touched the scar on the back of her neck where the chip had been.

She shook her head. She had been reading a report from ten years ago that Cadet Kyle had diarrhea for five minutes. Apparently, her brain was defending itself from reading about her former colleague's stool. She yawned and got up. She'd done a cursory cleanup, she'd have to sort out the papers tomorrow, because almost certainly none of Brightmoon's servants would have mastered the Horde's cataloging system. He understood him with great difficulty. Another way Shadow Weaver could make her life miserable even after death. She suspected that the sorcerer's adoration of bureaucracy stemmed from the fact that she had to control absolutely everything around her. She had to convince Hordak that thanks to the bureaucratic apparatus he would be like Prime, he would know everything. She shook her head in amazement.

Only a few days ago, she would have gone to Adora and slipped quietly under the covers...or deliberately woken her up to *spend some time together*, but she had flown off with Scorpia and Perfuma to Icarius, and would be back in a few weeks. She would love to fly with them, but even without her newest *hobby*, she had a lot of work to do. Mostly because of the approaching Victory Day. It's been almost five years since the three-decade-long war ended and Prime's rule over the galaxy ended. A day of great happiness and joy. On this occasion, it was decided to organize a great festival in Brightmoon, to which all inhabitants of Etheria and even beyond were invited. There will be great food, a show of the wonders of technology and magic, an exhibition showing the beauty and wonders of other planets, a meeting with the heroes

of Etheria ... And most importantly, a double wedding. Queen Glimmer and Royal Techmaster Bow, and Adora, or rather She-Ra, and Grand Marshal Catra. She had no idea why anyone would be interested. As it turns out, apparently half the planet was. And such a big event required special security measures. This was what she was supposed to do.

And that was why she should go to sleep, because tomorrow would be unlivable, but she didn't really want to. So she decided to make a tour of the castle. She left her cluttered junk room and, unseen, she and Melog wandered through the spacious corridors.

After the war, Brightmoon Castle became partly a ghost castle. One of them was her together with Melog. The Queensguard turned out to be a bunch of incompetent idiots who were fit only to present themselves nicely in armor. She couldn't believe how Hordak or Shadow Weaver hadn't infiltrated this building when even Scorpia and Emily had managed to sneak in undetected. After taking over as Grand Marshal, the first thing she did was fire three-quarters of the guards and rearm them. Modern armor and shock lances based on the Horde's old shock batons gave them at least minimal combat value, but she preferred to test them regularly by sneaking around after dark anyway. Besides, she enjoyed it.

At the beginning of the invasion, Prime, Brightmoon fell virtually without a fight, so it suffered minimal damage, which was later repaired. The town of Brightmoon below has nearly doubled in size since the end of the war. This was due to the former members of the Horde who decided to look for work in the capital, but also thanks to the refugees who came, or were brought by Adora aboard Darla, from various corners of the Prima Empire. The town of Brightmoon thus became the most cosmopolitan place on all of Etheria. And also the safest. As she looked out the window, she saw a shimmering energy shield dome. Created by Horde technology and a bit of Entrapta's genius, it was able to stop even intense orbital bombardment. Glimmer was very proud of it, much more so than the anti-aircraft artillery that was mounted on the walls, but it won her over when she said you

couldn't just defend yourself. Sometimes you also need to be able to bite back. They planned to create such a defense in every major settlement on Etheria. It will take time though. Fortunately, the industrial production of the former Fright Zone, now the land of the Scorpions, has been restored to at least partial efficiency. This was especially important now that Drill had been lost to the People's Rebellion.

The loss of the Drill... She looked toward where a mighty mountain range stretched beyond the horizon. "When did the fissures start to appear?" she thought. The first year after the war was full of uncertainty, but also hope. It wasn't easy, but they managed, and the next two years were the happiest time of her life. And then the subjects from all over Etheria came with the demand that the Queen should hide Etheria again, that she would take away the stars and everything would be as before. A shocked Glimmer said that even if she could have done it, she would never have done it, so they all dispersed disconsolately. Then, The Star Sisters seceded the Star Isles, claiming that they still had not received justice for the Pulsar's death and Halo's maiming during the time of the first alliance. There was little they could do about it, since Hordak had exiled himself to Beast Isle. There had been no legal execution on Etheri for three hundred years, so no one would comply with their demands anyway. And then Lonnie led the People's Rebellion to "overthrow the ailing regime of the princesses and put power in the hands of the people of Etheria." At first, no one took them seriously until Castle Crypto was captured by a large force of former Horde soldiers. The inhabitants of Dryl, abandoned years earlier by their princes, paid her homage. They couldn't get her out of there, not without bloodshed. Comrade General Lonnie won some support. She demanded the punishment of the former leaders of the Horde, i.e. Her, Hordak and Entrapta, as well as all clones, the removal of the rule from the princesses and the complete isolation of Etheria. That's why they had to be especially careful. No one has died so far, but many people have been injured, some seriously. They didn't know what to do with it. It was said that at night she meets with strange winged creatures who spoke a strange buzzing

language, but she considered them as fairy tales as stories about dragons, vampires or devils.

Hinking, she stood in front of a mural depicting Queen Angela. Brightmoon has been mourning for many years. First after King-Consort Micah, then after the queen who had ruled here for over three hundred years. She had never met the woman, not face to face, and now she wondered what she would think of her daughter befriending the former de facto leader of the Horde, even entrusting her with command of an army? *She's gone, so thinking about it is pointless.* But her spirit was felt everywhere. She was aware that she was responsible for her death ... Unless she met a worse fate. Glimmer had tried to ask Entrapta two years ago if she could rebuild the portal, but Entrapta had started fiddling with hers fixtures, pretending she hadn't heard what the queen was saying. She was not at all surprised by the behavior of the inventor, the previous time when the portal was built, the world was almost annihilated.

Looking at the mural, she decided that she would be able to talk to another person she knew was awake now. She went to the former Shadow Weavers garden. In the light of the stars and the dark moons, the great terrace looked quite lovely. After the death of the sorcerer, they decided that they would let the plants grow freely, the gardeners were only supposed to make sure that nothing withered. Glimmer asked asked that one bed of daisies is left here. Neither she nor Adora had any idea why, it was some kind of secret between the two sorcerers. Watching nature reclaim this place, she felt a bit of vindictive satisfaction. Like bureaucracy, Shadow Weaver loved gardening because it was about control and order. The plants could be pruned and shaped as they pleased, always obeying the will of the gardener. She wanted to know her charges just as much. If they disobeyed, she trimmed them... She shook her head. That mean woman had died five years, and she still thought about her almost every day. She was casting a shadow over her life and the lives of everyone she met. Bow once joked that the name Shadow Caster would suit her better, but then Adora seriously agreed with him. She was another Brightmoon ghost, her personal ghost. She didn't believe in ghosts

and souls and things like that, at least for most of her life. The people of Etheria believed in different versions of life after death. A better place, reincarnation or union with the universe. She was brought up with a distaste for spirituality, and what she experienced instilled in her cynicism and distrust. She had always believed that death was the end of everything. This thought filled her with bitter comfort, for oblivion would bring her an end to the torment that was her life. She wasn't so sure of anything now. However, the dark sorcerer will always accompany her. She will feel her presence in the wounds she carried in her heart. Fortunately, Shadow Weaver had faded into darkness and she would never see her again, but there was another ghost in Brightmoon she intended to visit.

"Hello, Catra." Mikah called to her, turning away from the beautifully decorated precious telescope. He could sense her and Melog, because he always surrounded himself with protective spells when he was about to engage in something that required attention, or just to rest.

"Hello Mikah." she smiled slightly when she became visible again "May I sit down?" she asked, and the sorcerer nodded. She sat down on one of the three chairs around the table.

"Did you find what you were looking for?" he asked, stroking Melog's head. She shook her head.

"No, but I found a lot of things I didn't want to find, and now I'm tired." She rubbed between her eyes.

"But you're too excited and nervous to sleep. I know that." - He smiled sadly. - "Though I've never been in your situation. You have the right to feel bad." - said the sorcerer, sitting down opposite her.

She nodded.

 "I thought I had it all behind me. And this wedding. Don't get me wrong, I'm glad me and Adora are getting married and

everything, but... I'm scared. Maybe if we didn't make it an interplanetary event."

She saw the sadness in the sorcerer's eyes as he began to talk.

"I understand you. When me and Angela got married, it was a big deal too. The first royal wedding in Brightmoon in three hundred and fifty years. And with an ordinary mortal, an ordinary sorcerer. Angela wanted to show everyone that this is the will of their queen and no one has the right to question it. It was then that the first alliance was made. I guess it's a good thing Glimmer didn't decide to make some kind of interplanetary agreement along the way."

"She considered it, but she wouldn't have had time to settle everything with our allies before the anniversary." she murmured and yawned. They sat at the table in silence for a few minutes

Many would argue that there should be hatred between the two of them rather than friendship. Mikah had every right to blame her for the death of the wife he loved so much. After the War, she asked him for forgiveness, but he had every right to refuse it. For what do the words mean? She had every right not to trust him, for he was a sorcerer and the ward of the one who had hurt her so much. But he forgave her, and a friendship developed between them. This was because they didn't really know each other before. Mikah had never met the old Catra, he knew her as she is. He had not known her hatred and self-destructive rage directed at everyone around her. And she heard more about him only on board the Darla. She had a general idea that Queen Brightmoon had a husband, but that was abstract knowledge to her. For almost everyone else, he was a symbol, their heroically dead king, whose death became proof of the evil represented by the Horde. Even Adora saw him like that. When they looked at him, they did not see a living man, but a ghost, someone who was supposed to be dead. She, the one who gained a new life after the War, saw in him a tired man who had lost almost everything.

Mikah sipped the weak wine from the goblet. She looked away. Because of Shado Weaver, she never drunk alcohol. The sorcereres had a penchant for the nasty, and officially illegal, tech-department moonshine, and she got even worse than usual when she drank it. She didn't want to risk becoming like that. Adora also rarely drank. She had a very weak head, and while she became adorably dorky when drunk after the events of the nanovirus, they were a little afraid to let her get into that state. Bow only drank alcohol on their trips with the Sea Hawk, and he usually got very sick afterwards, and Glimmer liked a glass of wine sometimes. Mikah, however, drank quite often, although he was still far from the border of alcoholism, but the queen asked her to keep an eye on him.

She looked at the beautiful telescope.

"Why are you doing this, actually? The starlight that reaches us dates back thousands of years. They are only shadows of a long-gone past." she asked frowning as Melog sniffed the device.

" Someone has to describe all the stars visible in our sky. Other civilizations have had millennia to do this. We have to make up for it" he replied with a friendly smile.

"At least let Entraptta build you a modern telescope. He'll probably design you a better one while you're brushing your teeth" she said skeptically.

"It's a gift from Empress of Eridani. It belonged to a great astronomer. It had survived the years of Prime's occupation in hiding, it would be foolish to lock him up in some closet now."

She reached for the book on the table. Its title was *A Thousands of Thousands Mas*ks. There were dark shapes on the cover.

"Shadow Weaver would love to read it." she said, wincing. *We are coming back to her again*

Mikah smiled mysteriously.
"If she had read this, our lives would have been completely

different. But she couldn't do it. It was written in Dreadcore, Mystacor's dark brother, and the only copy was in George and Lance's library."

"What is she talking about?" she asked and yawned again.

"About the mighty being called Nyarlathetop and theirs infinite faces."

She snorted contemptuously.
- Someone like those Iomdi and Sereni people they talk about on Eridani?

He nodded cautiously.
"In some way." he said slowly.

She put her feet on the table, feeling the exhaustion slowly taking over. Melog jumped on the table and cuddled up to her legs. She looked at the sky.

"You think the stars... That they are right?" she asked.

"Fortunately not." he said, covering her with his cloak. "I'll go to the valley of Shattered Armors in the morning, but tell Glimmer I'll be back for the wedding."
She nodded and closed her eyes. But before Mikah left, she asked

"Have you forgiven her? I did, but only because she died. It's easy to forgive the dead." and she fell asleep.

***
This chapter was originally supposed to never be, but I thought it would be useful to return to the old heroes, and I also needed to write down for myself what the situation on Etheria looks like.

In the Mountains of Dryl

"Lonnie, could you remind us again of the names of our allies?" Kyle asked anxiously, looking at the abyss stretching to the right.

She grit her teeth to hold back her anger.

"I've told you a million times. Mi-Go. That's four letters, two syllables! How come you can't remember that?" she growled, turning to the boy.

"When I think about them, I remember their buzzing, and then they start to remind me of bees, I'm afraid of them." said the blond man, adjusting his backpack.

She narrowed her eyes.

"Since when are you afraid of bees?!" she asked in amazement.

"About the time I found out I was allergic to bee venom," Kyle said, trying to keep his balance, though the backpack weighed heavily on his back.

"How do you know that? If a bee ever entered the Fright Zone and didn't die immediately, it committed suicide after looking around!" she said loudly, gesticulating violently with her hands.

"From the tests they did on us in the Fright Zone. They did to all of us. Turns out I'm allergic to bee venom, lactose and Luia's pollen. Rogelio." he pointed to a rather depressed lizard who carried a backpack heavier than' Kyle himself, had a strange black cylinder under his arm The Imp was cowering on his shoulder in the cold wind despite the warm sweater they made him sew he has allergy on feathers and you on shellfish"

"Shellfish?" She looked at him in consternation "I've never had any allergies to shellfish ... sooner cats..." she smiled inwardly.

"Because you've never eaten any, and you know, these Migu ..." he didn't finish, because she interrupted him.

"Mi-Go! I just told you! And I know where you're going, but I won't turn back! We need technology! The weapons these creatures offer us!" She screamed at Kyle until he backed up onto his back and kicked his legs like an upside-down beetle. She rolled her eyes and helped him up.

"I'm just worried about you and all of us. These creatures… I don't trust them, we've never heard of them before. Not before the end of the war." Kyle said in an apologetic voice. "They are terrible and do terrible things." he tried not to look at cylinder that was held by Rogelio . The lizard nodded at him.

"Highlanders from Drill were in contact with Mi-Go since the time of the First Ones. To these beings, your appearance is equally repulsive." A soft, slightly metallic voice came from the cylinder. A metal tentacle ending in a cybernetic eye slid out of the device. Rogelio and Kyle flinched simultaneously.

"They can be terrible, as long as they deliver what they promise" Lonnie said firmly.

"Comrade General Lonnie, are you going to order stopover?" asked a young woman with scarlet hair. Her tone was polite, but she had a sneer on her face. She held the sorcerer's staff in her hand.

"Comrade Scarlet, thank you very much for the question, but it was just a little consultation" she replied sharply.

Scarlet bowed humbly to her and walked forward. I *hate her, but she is necessary. Why do I always have to deal with people I hate? It's good that at least this time I'm giving the orders* she thought, smiling as if she wanted to growl at the red-haired woman.

"All right, Rogelio, Kyle, let's go! she called to them and goes towards Dead Mountain, where they were to meet their new

allies."

The Drill Mountains were the largest mountain range in Etheria in terms of both area and height. The weather here was absolutely unpredictable and violent. Rainless storms lasted here for years, and winds capable of carrying boulders weighing several tons rose in a few seconds, only to subside soon after. The mountains were criss-crossed by numerous tunnels that made traveling through the region easier, but unfortunately Lonnie's allies had chosen a rendezvous point away from most settlements and underground passages, as if they were deliberately trying to make it harder for them to get here.

The first time they sent their minions, two Boarpeople who brought a cylinder with Dr. Moors. It was already evening and she was making the rounds of the outer defenses. Her subordinates reluctantly explored the interior of the ancient stronghold. They had copied data from the datapad, probably stolen from Scorpia, because it had a picture of her, Entrapta, and Catra glued to the back, but the map still failed sometimes, as if the castle didn't want anyone to know its secrets. The Boarpeople came from one of the settlements scattered in the many valleys and valleys of the Dryl. She told the guards to let them in. They introduced themselves as friends of the Whisperers in the Dark and brought someone she should meet. She knew the stories of beings whispering in the dark on the mountaintops, but she didn't believe them. But then the cylinder spoke.

"Hello Comrade General Lonnie, I am Doctor Moors. We met before in the Fright Zone when you were a kid. Of course, I looked a bit different back then, but iassure you it's much better this way."

Then, as she stood in the courtyard of Castle Crypto surrounded by her subordinates, she thought for a moment that it was a joke and wondered if it wasn't another of Entrapta's ridiculous inventions that had gone mad. The Doctor extended his tentacled arms, and a small window appeared on the top of the cylinder through which they could see what was inside. Though she'd seen

a brain both in pictures and one preserved in formalin in anatomy class, nothing had prepared her for something like this.

"Ugh, hello, comrade doctor. I'm glad you're in good health, and we're glad you're happy in general." she said, confused.

" I learned that you are fighting for the people of Etheria... and I came here representing my... superiors. The Mighty and Ancient Mi-Go will gladly help you… in exchange for small favors."

It took her a moment to process the top hat's words.

"They're from there, from the stars." She pointed upwards where the first stars of the evening could be seen. She was perhaps not as distrustful of them as most of Etheria's inhabitants,

"Ahh, just like our ancestors. Few have the right to call themselves natives of Etheria. But the Mi-Gos were here before the arrival of the First Ones, and they will wander the dark emptiness of space on their wings long after our civilizations are nothing but dust."

She winced at such boasting. Hord Prime had made her immune to such talk. She had once believed the Horde's propaganda and still considered herself a soldier, but she could tell when someone wanted to appear more powerful than they really were. She looked at the cylinder from which several tentacles sprouted. Some apparently were used for locomotion, others for manipulating objects, and still others ended in what looked like eyes.

"You can trust him... Comrade General. I've heard of these beings. They are a highly ancient race that possesses technology beyond anything we possess." said Scarlett. In her intensely green eyes, she saw delight mixed with greed. *I don't trust you, much less trust someone who packs living brains in cans.*

"What do you have to offer!? Just be brief! I have a Rebellion to lead!" she said menacingly looking at the doctor locked in cylinder.

"Like Scarlet said, we're offering you technology that will give you an advantage over the princesses." he said. Imp flew to the top hat and sniffed it, then touched it with his hand. The Doctor directed one of his tentacles at him, and the winged man jumped back. Rogelio took it on his shoulder and stared hard at the ominous creature.

The doctor was right. She had several thousand battle-hardened soldiers with her and a lot of equipment they had managed to get hold of. However, Drill's production capacity was limited compared to the Fright Zone, and many of technicians sought employment somewhere in the realms. Most importantly, against all the princesses, wizards and moon-cursed She-Ra, they could only stand Scarlet, who was self-taught sorcereress.

"Okay, we can talk preliminarily, but be warned if…" She wanted to sound menacing, but her brain cut her off.

" I'll contact my… friends. I will stay here with you as a sign of good will." he said while signaling the Boarpeople to leave

The meeting was to take place in the courtyard of Castle Crypto, surrounded by her soldiers. Most of them wore reworked Horde armor, but repainted silver. Her private guard was clad in experimental heavy armor developed for the alliance before switching sides. Only a dozen or so were made, and Catra and Hordak were not interested in increasing the survivability of the soldiers, especially since they were expensive in materials. Fortunately, her technicians were able to start production, although it was time-consuming. *Neither Hordak, nor Catra, nor even Hord Prime had a personal elite guard.* she thought proudly. A few towers that were mounted on the moors were directed inwards. They waited in the light of accursed stars and dark moons. She, Kyle, Rogelio, those she trusted, and Scarlet and Doctor Moors, those she need, were waiting in the square. The young sorcereress was dressed in the robes of her trade that had once been sewn for her. The dark blue outfit was almost black in the dim light. A mystic, as she liked to call herself smiled mysteriously. For two days, the Doctor "sat" in Entrapta's former

workshop, converted into the main workshop, as if he were just another strange object abandoned here by the former mistress of the fortress. Now he stood with his tentacles outstretched and waited.

" I don't understand, if you could contact them, why can't we?" Kyle asked, nervously looking around.

"Oh, you could talk to my friends too, if you had the same transformation as me. I assure you it's worth it." one of the tentacles reached towards the blond-haired boy's face, and he jumped back with a short cry. Rogelio hit her hard with clear disgust.

"Won't you protect your boys from our sweet abomination?"Scarlett asked. She gave her a menacing look.

:"They are not my boyfriends, our relationship is much more complicated and it is none of your business." she threatened the sorcerer. She just smiled evilly at her.

"Who would have thought that life would ever become so complex." Everything seemed so simple in the Fright Zone, at least until our blonde friend started honoring and the cat showed her claws.

She narrowed her eyes. They weren't friends with each other. Scarlet wasn't friends with anyone, but unlike Catra, she didn't annoy the cadets either. She only annoyed the trainers, but she never got in Shadow Weaver's way. It was all the easier because most of the time she was cleaning toilets or standing guard at the treatment plant. The number of statutory penalties exceeded even today's Grand Marshal, but she never made the dark sorceress angry. *Did your talent show up then? Is that why you didn't want Shadow Weaver to notice you? So she doesn't get rid of you as a potential competitor.*

"It's really better for you to keep quiet."said Lonnie

"Indeed, you are right. I'm silent now." she said turning away from her

They waited two hours. Dryl's great batbats flew blotting out the stars, unconcerned with the sight that so terrified many of her planet's inhabitants. When Mi-Go showed up, at first they thought it was one of those huge wolf batbats that were supposed to live deep in the mountains and supposedly could snatch a young flanneling. However, the wingspan was much larger. The creature landed soundlessly on six limbs. She gasped at the sight of him. She was very tolerant of beings with a different physique, she slept with Rogelio after all, but that being…. It looked a bit like a cross between a crustacean and a cockroach, but it wasn't covered in chitin, but something rubbery in texture. It was difficult for her to determine where the head began, she could only see something flat, finished with poppies where the face was. The legs were much more flexible than those of insects. The pair of pincers was more delicate than Scorpia's, but she felt they allowed her to manipulate objects much more freely.

"Good night Comrade General. You can call me Connector." he said. His voice sounded like bees buzzing, but it was understandable. Imp curled up on Rogelio's shoulder, and the lizard himself didn't look very confident. Kyle looked at his friends anxiously.

"Hello, Connector. We were supposed to negotiate a deal…" she said, though she wasn't sure exactly what she wanted.

"Oh yeah. Our species has made deals with… young races for hundreds of millions of years. We will be happy to get along with you. You pulled the planet out of the dimensional pocket and defeated the Horde, so you have credit with us" he croaked. She preferred not to explain that none of this was their fault. In fact, they spent almost the entire occupation hiding in the Crimson Wastes. She wasn't proud of it, but they were ordinary people, not wizards or princesses. They had no powers... But they didn't bring the Horde at least...

"What do you have to offer us?" she asked. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Scarlet licking her lips as she studied the creature with absolute fascination. The creature reached under it with its pincers and took out something that it must have held under it with organic grips, perhaps with small tentacles? Then he placed the oblong object at her feet

"You gave me a stick, a moondamn stick! - she shouted. *Are these beings just trying to make fun of the lesser races?* She felt the creature laugh.

"It's Staff of the Wanderer of the Infinite Sky from Leng." Mi-Go said, and she heard Scarlet suck in a breath.

"Leng? Is this somewhere in Prime Empire? Another lost First ones colony?" she asked skeptically, nudging the stick with her shoe.

"The nightmarish Plateau of Leng s not on any planet but in Dreamlands. You can get there mainly by falling into mystical sleep, or through secret cracks in the fabric of the reality. Supposedly, some of them are here in Dryl. Flesh-eating ghouls and mysterious denizens of Leng live on the plateau. In its valleys there are gods and horrors beyond description. I'd like to go there someday." said the mystic in a dreamy voice.

If Shadow Weaver and Entrapta had a child, it would be you she thought, and shuddered because captured Prime's technology made it possible. She reached for the staff and was surprised to feel the power, just like once when she was in the Black Opal chamber… Or near She-Ra… It was made of an unfamiliar metal. It was covered in runes she couldn't read, but they certainly weren't made by the First Ones. "It's rather good? They created the heart of Etheria. They made the sword." She tilted her head to the side.

"For Honor..." She started to whisper and felt herself blush. It's idiotic. *I'm Lonnie, the comrade, not dumb heroine.*

|It is made of pure adamantium. It can withstand even the impact of Sword of Protection. It has been enchanted by great power… Try it yourself." the creature buzzed.

She gripped the metal staf with both hands, as she had been taught all these years in the Fright Zone. This weapon was slightly longer that one she was training and much lighter than she thought it should be. It fit well in the hand. She walked over to one of the several tanks parked in the yard becaouse of lack of a better place. She took off the canvas sheet and took a swing. As she hit, she heard a wailing whistle. The tank's armor cracked at the point of impact. She stared dumbfounded at what she had done.

"You know Lonnie, we have a limited number of tanks so don't destroy any more."Kyle said stunned as he stared at the damaged machine. She smiled triumphantly.

It's… she couldn't find the right word…

"This is only part of the artifact's capabilities. Touch the first rune from the handle by pointing the tip of the stick at an object." the creature buzzed

She shrugged and pointed to a metal box. First, she felt the stick become an extension of her own hand, and then... Then the box lifted slightly above the ground. She felt like she was lifting herself. She heard those strange wailing whistling noises over and over.

"Move the cane a little and see how it moves." said the Connector. She did as he said. She could move the box in the air as if she was holding it in her own hand. She did whatever she wanted with it. She smiled and took swings. The box flew and hit the walls of the fortress with all its might. Sweat ran down her back.

"The heavier the object is or the more rapidly you move it, the more you tire... Now point the Staff to a place, as long as it's not too far or too high." stated Mi-Go. She pointed to the seat in front

of Rogelio and pressed. She saw a flash, then a wailing howl, and suddenly she was in front of the lizard, smelling the stew they had eaten today. She took a deep breath. It was amazing!

"The rune takes a minute to recharge. The range is about three hundred meters. Now touch one of your friends." the Connector suggested. She hesitated. She didn't like the suggestion very much. The creature didn't seem trustworthy to her.

"It won't hurt anyone, I swear." Mi-Go said. She cautiously approached Rogelio and asked.

" I can?"

After a moment's thought, the lizard nodded. She touched him with the tip of her staff. Then his eyes were covered with mist.

"What happened to him?" she asked fearfully.

"You took over his mind. Now, until the next sunrise, he will obey your will." said the creature.

"I don't want it to be like this, tell me how to make it like it was before, because you won't get out of here alive." she threatened Mi-Go.

"Hit him pretty hard." the creature buzzed.

"I… I'm sorry," she said, and punched him hard in the stomach."Her friend doubled over, but his eyes regained their sparkle. He began to purr loudly, gesticulating violently. It pointed to a stick. It's on Lonnie and finally on Mi-Go. Lonnie had known Rogeiio since she was a child, so she understood what he meant. She turned to the Connector and started toward him, the artifact in her hands. She hit him with all her might. Mi-Go flew to the castle wall. A blow that would have shattered a tank didn't make much of an impression on the creature, except for a large indentation. The staff was covered in yellow gore that smelled of ammonia.

"It was exactly as I said, it not hurt him. You hit him. You could have waited." There was no guilt in the creature's buzzing voice, only amusement. She felt tears come to her eyes.

"Throughout the occupation, we managed to avoid being chipped. Prime never had any power over us, he didn't break us and…"

"You now have a fraction of his power. As one of the few on this planet, you can control others like puppets. And you received this gift from us as a gesture of goodwill. Think about what else you can get from us as our cooperation develops. I can see in your eyes that you've made up your mind."

She closed her eyes. The creature was right. Even now she could feel the power flowing from the staff...

"Okay, tell me what you want." she asked grimly.

"Meet us in a week at the top of the dead mountain. Bring as many Sorcerer Crystals as you can." it buzzed and took off into the air. She noted with satisfaction that his flight was not straight. She looked at the staff and tightened her hands on the handle.

I need power and they will give it to us

So the five of them walked to Dead Mountain, though only one of the five of them was really happy with the trip. They wore thick fur cloaks that they put over their new-old armor, which are the Horde armor, which they repainted silver and in place of the old Horde symbol, they inked the sign of the People's Rebellion, which is Etheria surrounded by its moons. Kyle and Rogelio carried old shock batons, and the lizard he had blaster obtained from Prima Clones. In addition to her staff, she had a rock breaker. Larger and bulkier versions of this were used by the Horde after they incorporated Castle Crypto to break gates. However, it was a smaller and more practical version, often used by the inhabitants of Dryl for ... many purposes. It fired a small recoilless explosive capable of shattering a metal door. "Or someone's skull," she

smiled grimly. For now, they avoided killing as much as they could, but she feared that one day someone would die and the conflict would escalate. They must be ready for it, and that's why they pinned so much hope on this meeting ... at least for her.

Rogelio has been gloomy and angry since she used the staff on him. He was reluctant to *talk* to anyone without being asked. Kyle was trying to lead her away from her goal. He feared that dealing with these beings would bring misfortune upon them. She loved them both with all her heart. They have been with her forever and have never let her down. But they will not deter her from what she has decided. But she didn't want to lose them. He has to do something to convince them of this decision.

Of course, Scarlet had no worries. They hadn't been friends before the victory, and they weren't now. She had no idea what had happened to that woman in the first three years since the end of the War. She had learned sorcery somewhere, but certainly not in Mystakor. Her power wasn't great, but she could do some things even Shadow Weaver didn't know. She came to them, to the camp in the Crimson Waste with a map of Castle Crypto, without which the entire Rebellion would not have been possible. It was with the seizure of Entrapta's former seat that their activities began in earnest, and the Queen and Catra now had to reckon with them... Only it didn't change the fact that she still resented that woman. Maybe not as much as Catra, who had betrayed them twice, but she still annoyed her. Scarlet didn't believe in their cause, all she wanted was…power? authority? She wasn't sure. *Will she be my very own Shadow Weaver?* she thought anxiously.

Imp became their mascot, but also something more. Prime placed a high bounty on him, and during the occupation they had to protect him. Most former Horde soldiers would have given up the little spy Hordak without hesitation, but he was as much a victim to the three of them as they were. Abandoned by its creator in the last moments of the war, it required care. He wasn't a kid of course, actually he was a bit older than her. Now most of the soldiers liked him, even respected him for his scouting abilities.

She didn't know what she thought of her "Father". Hordak had his new family on Beast Island, and he was out of their reach...at least for now.

At last they came to the foot of Dead Mountain. It wasn't particularly high. It looked like a rounded solid block of granite, completely out of place with the rest of the soaring peaks of the Drill. Climbing it would be easier than all the walking here, but she decided they deserved a rest anyway.

"Let's stay here for a while and eat something." she said in the most cheerful voice she could muster. Kyle smiled and unwrapped their provisions. They were pies stuffed with spicy vegetables and meat. They were cold but still tasty. After leaving the Fright Zone, they vowed never to eat food packets and enjoy real food. The meal made even Rogelio cheer up, and he offered her curdled milk. It was like before...

"It is interesting." said Scarlett. She was standing by a tall stele that at first they took for a bizarre signpost. Its crown looked like a spider turned backwards, with eight legs supporting a spherical stone. It was covered with writings in the same language as those on her staff.

"Atlach-Nacha." the red-haired sorcerer suddenly said "The Spinner of Darkness. It's quite funny, considering our experience"

" Can you read it!?" Kyle exclaimed in surprise. The sorcereress turned to them confused, as if they had caught her doing something wrong.

"I know this language a bit" she said, obviously hiding something from them.

"And what is written on my staff." she asked the red-haired woman sharply, but the other one answered her smiling contemptuously.

"Just what the Connector told you." Scarlet said

The good mood was gone. The pancakes didn’t tasted anymore.

"This bodes badly for everything. And those shellfish…" Kyle said in a scared voice

"Mi-Go are fungi." Scarlet corrected.

"Fungi can be poisonous." Kyle continued.

"Just say you want us to turn back!" She yelled at him, blushing furiously.

"It wouldn't be such a stupid idea after all." The blonde said, and Rogelio nodded his agreement.

"And what? How do you envision the next fight? Without weapons from these creatures, we have no chance of winning!" She felt despair rising in her heart.

"You know, Lonnie, maybe it's time to think about negotiating. The Queen will certainly accede to some of our demands." he said, and there was a terrible silence. It seemed to them that even the wind howling through the jagged peaks had ceased. At first she wanted to explode with rage and threaten them. Intimidate them into obeying her commands. *I am not Catra.* She took a deep breath and said.

"Some demands? What are we to give up? To bring justice for what was done to us, to all the people of Etheria? Giving up the rule of the people, not to those who have it just because they wield magical power? From ensuring the safety of the entire planet? Tell me what's not important anymore. "she looked at him hard

"I don't know, but we can make concessions in each of them. We don't have to take revenge…" Kyle said slowly.

"You think I want revenge? We don't even have anything to avenge, except for our ruined lives! Hordak sits on Beast Island and pretends to he didn’t want to do anthing wrong. and they're

making Catra and Adora's wedding a moondamn state event! Tell me, does our everscreaming leader live in conditions like those he sent to their deaths? No, they've built themselves a lovely outpost where they're happily doing research. And all those who died during the war. It was mistake? Horde citizens, especially us cadets, are also victims. We gave our lives in the fight for fantasies, for lies! We don't have a past or a future. All we can do is fight, and we've been made damn good soldiers." she was explaining, but Kyle cut her off.

"We can sew, we can repair shoes, and Rogelio is a great cook." he said with a nervous smile. She chose to ignore him.

"They tell us about conditioning and the warped shaping of the psyche. and us? We too have been conditioned and perverted, have any of us done as much evil as he has? Except for Catra, of course." She clenched her fists "At least Hordak was imprisoned, although with better conditions than those in which most of the citizens of the Horde had to exist. But Catra was rewarded for her crimes. Throughout her rule, we tried to kill or imprison our former colleague because she resented the fact that she had abandoned her. Her, not all of us, by going over to the enemy's side. And now they slept together and everything is fine, and the fact that we risked our health and lives, that we hurt others, does not count anymore? And why was all this? In the name of… that they took offense at each other? And now Catra is the Grand Marshal, and everyone is happy, though if Prime hadn't arrived, she'd still be scheming." she took a few steps back and forth to calm herself down.

"But you and Catra… you never liked each other and…" Kyle started, but she cut him off

"Because when we were nine years old, this psychopath attacked me for no reason! She's Shadow Weaver's true daughter and she can't deny it. She and Entrapta almost killed all of us twice. Twice!" she laughed unhappily: "Entrapta is not much better. She had no qualms about making deadly weapons until Catra got mad at her and sent her to Beast Island. The mere fact that she

married someone like Hordak says a lot about what kind of person she is. They should all answer for their actions. So did Shadow Weaver, but she got away with it because she was dead."

She crouched down to think for a moment. Out of the corner of her eye, she noticed that Scarlet smiled when she talked about the fate of the dark sorcereress, but she had no intention of guessing what the red-haired girl was thinking.

"Power should be transferred to the people. The fact that princesses have magical powers does not entitle them to rule over people in any way. Let's look at Scorpia. We all know she's nice and has always treated us well, but let's be honest. She was no good at leading a squad, let alone running a country. Entrapta has left her own kingdom, Adora, well... She doesn't rule anything. I don't know much about the others, but I doubt it's any better. The people of Etheria suffered for thirty years in a war they could not win. And it probably would have taken twice as long, but the queen's mother had died, and then she used ancient technology with Entrapta's prudence to get her revenge. And not only did she hardly destroy Etheria herself, but she also brought Prime to us. So what if She-Ra beat him. Now anyone can come here and attack us. The universe is full of Hordaks." she said and looked up at the sky covered with stars.

"Only darkness comes from the stars.: she said softly.

"The true darkness lurks in the space between the stars, promising power to anyone who proves worthy." Scarlet interjected unexpectedly. She looked at her surprised. She had no idea how much of her speech the sorceress had listened to, but she didn't really care, because she wasn't the one who was addressing her speech. Kyle and Rogelio looked like they had taken her words to heart, or at least thought about them.

"I understand Lonnie, but I'm afraid that ... everything will get out of control and we will only make things worse." Kyle said in a depressed voice.

For sure everything will get out of control, it always happens. That's why we need to prepare. But she patted him on the shoulder.
- Don't worry, everything will be fine, now come on - she knew she was lying to her friend - We can't be late, it would look bad.

Dead Mountain was called that way for a reason. On the way, they did not encounter anything living, not even a tiny insect. It was also very cold here, the icy wind penetrating under the furs. Kyle was shivering from the cold, Rogelio took out the blanket and covered him with it. However, they did not slow down because they had to hurry to meet their new allies. They reached the top almost perfectly, whenever the dark moons were in the sky. The wind howled, and now everyone was chattering their teeth. But so far no one was there "You're not afraid of an ambush?" asked the blonde haired man,

"They wouldn't gain much from it" she said, though deep down she wasn't sure. These creatures were so alien.

They came in silence. Five winged figures descended on the flattened mountaintop. She recognized the Connector, to her disappointment it looked like the wound she had inflicted on him had already healed. The other two looked like soldiers. They had strange blasters in their paws that looked organic. Strange tentacles were wrapped around their pincers. Next Mi-Go was bigger than the others and had strange egg-like packages underneath him. The last one had a thicker 'skin' with many long protuberances. There was a strange antenae in the middle of the torso.

"Good night, Comrade General Lonnie. I am the Overseer and I run this small facility. I am very happy about our cooperation. We brought you weapons in exchange for sorcery crystals. " Mi-go buzzed, and Rogelio and Kyle took out the crystals. Mi-Go set up the containers, which opened and a terribly stinking mist began to come out of them. With some disgust, her friends began

extracting organic items from them that were similar to the ones the warriors carried with them.

"These smaller eldrith arquebuses which strike with cold and are capable of killing the tissues of a living thing." Said the Overseer. His voice was stronger than the Connector. Kyle took the arquebus and fired it at the stone, which cracked, most likely from the water freezing inside.

"The larger ones are the Howling Muscets. They can tear flesh from bones with sound." said the Overseer. Rogelio grabbed the muscet and fired at the boulder, which shattered with a crash.

"And these are the Hunter's Claws. They are sharper than steel" the Mi-Go leader said. She reached into the container and pulled out a gauntlet that wrapped tentacles around her wrist. It wasn't a nice feeling. She'd never had an octopus in her hands, but she suspected it wasn't half as disgusting as this thing. Still, the strange gauntlet fit perfectly. She walked over to the remains of the boulder and hit the largest piece with all her strength. Cracks appeared on the surface of the stone.

"Now Catra I have claws too" she said softly and turned away, then turned to the Overseer with satisfaction.

"It's great equipment. We will bring you more crystals soon.

"We won't be needing the crystals for a while. We have another request for you." the Mi-Go leader buzzed. She felt furious, though she should have expected it.

"What?! That was not the deal!" she shouted and Kyle, Rogelio and even Scarlet came after her.

"But there was no deal. You provided us with the crystals as we requested, and we provided you with the weapons. Now we're asking you for something else." replied the Overseer. She clenched her fists, including the one in the glove, and drawled slowly.

"What do you want."

"Originally there was a listening base. We were watching the great project of the first ones then, but unfortunately we were detected and Mara in her new form slew all my former subordinates. Fortunately, they did not detect our base, and I bred new subordinates for myself." the Overseer buzzed without emotion, telling about the death of his kin.

She narrowed her eyes, not knowing how to react to Mi-Go's story.

"Mara? Was that the previous She-ra? How could you know her, that was a thousand years ago." she asked suspiciously. These creatures have never lied before. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw the doctor awake and his tentacles extend. He was talking to the Liaison in a language they didn't know. She didn't like it, but she had to deal with the Overseer.

"Much more time passed. In the meantime, however, a mysterious event on a cosmic scale has occurred and my memory no longer works as it used to. Therefore, I am asking you for help in contacting my kin. To do that, I need you to build a relay a bit…"

"Need our help to contact other Mi-Gos who have managed to escape the wrath of the Galactic Horde?" she asked a bit skeptically.

"Our activities in the Empire have probably been extinguished, and those who remained went into sleep mode." the Overseer calmly explained.

"Those who stayed? The rest of your people hid on those planets that Prime missed for some reason?" she asked curiously. She'd heard a little about how things were with the old Empire.

She suddenly felt nauseous, her teeth began to ache, and the blood in her temples throbbed. She looked at her companions. Judging by their expressions, they felt it too.

"What are you doing to us?" she asked confused.

"Oh well, my joy is painful. Know that it's not easy to make me laugh." Said the Overseer. He was making strange movements with his pincers "I forgot this place is full of ignorant people. You believe, or rather you want to believe, that Hord Prime has conquered the entire known universe. Oh, his empire occupied only a small part of one of thousands of galaxies. Even in the one in which we exist, powers surpassing him have probably already rise.

She felt cold sweat running down her back. She got dizzy. *I always knew. The universe is a scary place, but it's not full of Hordaks, it's full of Primes. No one realizes the danger that threatens the entire planet. Are others so blind?* she thought in horror.

"We will try to help you... but you will have to give us more... Weapons and other equipment. Your new request will be difficult to fulfill." she said, crossing her arms over her chest and trying to look as threatening as she could.

"Don't worry, we'll help you. We'll send you the plans. Just remember, you have to hurry. It's been five years since you pulled the planet out of Despondos. Your queen's deed has not gone unnoticed by the current powers of the galaxy. It's only a matter of time until someone takes an interest in your home." said the Mi-Go leader.

Kyle placed a hand on her right shoulder.

"Lonnie, that's not a good idea. You remember what happened last time, when someone from off-planet was attempted to be sumoned... " he asked in a worried voice.

"There is nothing to fear, Comrade General. It is said that the Mi-Go have built colonies near every major world and have never

attempted to conquer one. As you can see, they have better ways to get what they want." said Scarlet

Finally she nodded.

"It's a choice of the lesser evil. Anyone who wants to win must be prepared to make difficult decisions." she said slowly. Kyle frowned but nodded in agreement with her.

When it comes to difficult decisions. I have another proposition for you she heard in her own head. She jumped up in fear. Her companions gave her questioning looks, but she said nothing, for she guessed that the Overseer was talking to her.

Don't be afraid, I can't read your mind. Back to my proposal. Most of you have not very volatile minds. We try to save the few notable ones from the fragility of your bodies by placing them in cylinders. However, there is one mind in this world whose genius can amaze even us. We want Entrapta's brain.

She felt her face turn green with disgust. It wasn't a fate she would condemn anyone to.

He didn't pretend to be so shaken. I have read your demands. You want to kill her lover, the father of her child, and sentence her to life imprisonment in Castle Crypto, where such great tragedies befell her. What we do to her will be an act of mercy. And our gratitude will be immense. We know where the First Ones warship is hidden. We will help you find it and run it.

She nodded her head, they can feel her nausea rising…
***
This chapter was also not planned. You can see a bit of my national flaw. We Poles believe that a good rebellion is a failed rebellion. And if the rebellion is winning, then something has gone wrong.

-

Silence and Scream

Rosie always tried to eat alone first before eating with others. She was very fond of talking, and eating and talking would be uncomfortable for her.

" Well, I'm an intern working for Dr. Qin. The university pays my salary for next half a year. My job is to help the doctor with everything. - She looked askance at the doctor." Which usually comes down to this, I have to carry her equipment.

Ysoka snorted.

"You have to work hard to get anything done. Nothing comes for free... Unless you're an aristocrat." she ostentatiously tried not to look at Lady Cala "You will learn how to handle expensive equipment. It will come in handy in your life for sure." the doctor continued. Rosie clenched her teeth tightly but didn't answer her.

The others ate dinner together at the table. There was Akitonese rice with vegetables, spicy soup with lizard tails, and some kind of reptile bird. The latter was too dry, but still tasty. There was also candied fruit and sweet alcohol made of something like apples, and juice. None of the dishes were salted, which Arkan-tar said meant they respected the guests here. Rosie had no opinion on that. After carrying the Doctor's equipment, she felt so hungry and tired that she absolutely didn't care. Now she looked at the others.

Lady Cala ate like a dame, listening politely as she told her about herself. Miss Daisy sat to one side and thoughtfully ate her dinner, washing it down with sweet Liquor. She liked the young aristocrat, though she was a little intimidating. Her guardian… There was something dark about her, but also some sadness that shone through the dark veil she covered herself with.

"So what's your plan? Because you understand that I'm not one of those who are in planning? You tell me where to aim and I'm the one pulling the trigger." Dilayla said with her mouth full of food. The woman looked soured all the time, as if she had been forced to drink vinegar. It was as tough as the steel from which her cybernetic prosthetics were made. She also drank alcohol, though she looked like she could drink more than they were brought. She eyed them all suspiciously.

"Well, the plan is not complicated, just difficult to execute. We need to find a ship on a planet where no one seems to want to go to where we want to go." said Arkan-tar. He struck her as a charming scholar who had explored places in the galaxy she had never dreamed of. Only there was something about him…as if he was always pleased with his cleverness.

"Do we have a choice? We'll tell someone like the Lord Admiral something went wrong? This planet was once supposed to be a prosperous colony, so maybe there is an old ship left somewhere... Or maybe someone will want to go in the same direction as us. - finished Rechiza, digging the meat on the plate with a fork. In her opinion, Lashunti was reserved, but also very penetrating. From the moment of their first conversation, she was very cold towards Miss Daisy. She seemed to notice that the woman was wearing a holographic mask. Rosie had noticed it the first time they met, she had good eyesight, which she often used to compensate for her lack of hearing. She understood that something like this might inspire mistrust, but she had the impression that Lashunti didn't trust anyone. She was a little terrified of it, but she understood that everyone has different experiences and that they shape their personal worlds. For her, most people she came across were kind and showed her support.

"I have the vague impression, my dears, that you regard this expedition as, at best, an attempt to infiltrate an enemy camp, and at worst a suicide mission." said Lady Cala, rising. She leaned towards them, looking down at them.

"Honey, this is a suicide mission. We're going to the Ravaged Zone, where no one comes back. Only death lurks there." Dilayla said with a predatory smile.

"If only death awaits us there, then why are you coming with us on this journey?" If my memory serves me right, then you are a mercenary – the aristocrat asked with a gentle smile.

"I've just been paid so much that if everything goes well and, most importantly, I survive, I'll have enough to spend the rest of my life farting." The half-elf straightened up in her chair, crossing her arms behind her head. She put her feet on the table, apparently not caring what others thought. Rosie, however, was convinced that the mercenary was hiding something. Something important to her.

"If you say so…" Lady Cala shrugged. "My family… The founder of my house is from there. Her name was Mara and she fought for that place and gave her life for it. If Etheria is worth dying for, then it can't be that terrible."

"I've seen soldiers die for a pile of rubble. Besides, since you left this whole Eterntia thing, it wasn't much fun there, was it?" Dilayla said and yawned.

Arkan-tar stood up and said

"I think we're looking too far into the future. It will be a long time before we reach Etheria. We may never get there if it turns out that along the way there are threats that even *the Research and Exploration Fleet* will not resist. In fact, no one requires us to fight what we encounter there. It can be said that in our hearts we all want to believe what Lady Cala says, but our mind tells us to prepare for what Dilayla warns us against."

Everyone nodded reluctantly, as if it was a compromise that no one liked. By the time the others had gone back to eating, Rosie had gotten up and started speaking in sign language as the gloved voiceover began translating everything aloud.

"I... I'm just an intern. I don't even remember my family. My capsule was found on the border of the Pact Worlds and a couple of learned people decided to take care of me. I have no one. My capsule had been in space for hundreds of years while I was frozen. I'm just a deaf-mute girl assigned by fate and the gods to this mission. I know that all this can end tragically for us ... But deep down I feel that we are part of something great. Something unusual. What can change the world." she said and blushed, feeling that she had made a fool of herself in front of everyone. "These are real travelers, they know what they're doing. I just carry things." she thought and looked down. The others were silent for a moment, but finally Lady Cala stood up, walked over to them, put her hand on her shoulder, and said.

"You have a big and brave heart, Rosie. It's good that you're with us." The aristocrat smiled at her and Rosie felt her blush.

Miss Daisy looked at her thoughtfully for a moment.

"So you're an orphan?" she asked thoughtfully. Rosie turned to her and smiled.

"I think so, I don't remember my parents and after so many years probably all my loved ones have already gone to a better place. Maybe it's better that I remember very little?" she said, feeling a strange, indescribable emptiness in her heart.

"Miss Daisy knows very well about raising orphans. She raised me and many others and they all remember her fondly." said Lady Cala, smiling at her tutor.
Miss. Daisy pursed her lips tightly and spoke hard.

"Indeed, they will never forget me."

Dilayla was more annoyed than usual. Previously, she had thought that the gloomy and overly secretive Rechiza and the nosy and insistently polite Arkan-tar would get on her nerves, but they were just an itch on her back. You could get used to them eventually. The rest of her companions began to annoy her very quickly. Dr.

Qin is a over smart scholar trying to mask her lack of creativity with academic snobbery. Miss Daisy… She was strange and far too gloomy for someone who claimed to be an aristocrat's tutor. She had a dark past, though Dilayla shouldn't remind anyone of that. Rosie Pearl was kind and naive, though there could only be someone raised on Absalom, though later it turned out that her story was a bit more complicated. She was afraid that the world would eat her up, chew her up and spit out her torn corpse. She was pretty, but she would feel bad hitting on her. But it was Lady Cala that worried her the most. At first she expected to be a pretty sweet idiot with too much money, not enough brains, who had fantasized about a magical quest after reading some old chronicles. Instead, she met a beautiful, strong and smart young woman who knows exactly what she wants. And that was unsettling, for such people did not engage in such endeavors unless their minds were tainted by madness or fanaticism, and she saw neither in her. She was way too beautiful and smart, too perfect. It made her uneasy in some way, though she couldn't quite tell how. He has to watch out for her...

After dinner, when the dishes had been removed, Lady Cala spread out a map of the city on the table.

"Listen, we need to find someone willing to sell us, or at least rent a ship that will take us to Etheria. I know it won't be easy, but we have to make it." She looked at them surprisingly imperiously, which contrasted so much with her earlier image of a nice and understanding girl, but Dilayla was not surprised. After all, she was an aristocrat, and what they had no problems with putting on such *masks* they needed.

"I can definitely visit the canteen at the port. They say they serve pretty good beer for this planet," Arkan tar said, smiling contentedly.

"It's good that you've found the perfect place to work, Arkan." said Rechiza sarcastically. Lashunti asked.

"I guess this is Respite." said Lady Cala, looking over her notes. They sell Coffee, Tea, and Ashrak there. The latter is a sobering drink made from the underground lichen that grows on Atrax.

"Yes, it's very tasty. I will go there. Anyone coming with me?" She asked, smiling slyly " Maybe you, Miss Daisy? You seem to like tea and other types of drink." she asked the grim elf. Miss Daisy turned to her and looked at her carefully, she answered slowly.

"Well, I don't like the sun here, but I'll gladly take the offer."

Well, Dilayla had already noticed that the mysterious sorceress wasn't pouring by the collar. The same could be said about her too. She was a mercenary, at least in theory, and had gotten drunk quite often, though she always went sober to the battlefield.

Speaking of liquors she got up and leaned over the table.

"And what is the name of the haven here for mercenaries and other adventurers?" she asked looking at the aristocrat. She if she'll play innocent or show off.

"There is a bar... Red Water. I think it's run by a Pahtra, a veteran of the Tarak War.

Rechiza frowned.

"Isn't that where the Lord Admiral comes from?" she asked, frowning.

"Yes, there was a civil war there, although I don't know the details, except that it was very bloody. Our great commander was then exiled, and began a new career. In fact, it seems to have worked out for him. It doesn't change anything, we don't tell anyone about our true purpose of our mission anyway, do we?" she raised an eyebrow.

"Okay, now that we've all divided up the chores, you can go" I have some errands to run here. said Lady Cala and rolled up the

maps.

"I'll stay here and check the equipment. Rosie will help me. said the doctor, stretching herself out on the sofa,
- Unless someone takes me, right?" Maybe someone needs me more? - asked the intern, looking pleadingly at the others. Dilayla sighed. "The rat will torment her if I don't do anything"

"You can come with me. – she asked the girl getting up – Just remember, I don't avoid brawl. "She went to put on her power armor." Rosie jumped for joy.

As she donned the power armor, she thought about her past.

Her real life began with a scream.

That was over thirty years ago. It wasn't that much for a half-elf, but that's when she became what she is now. She was sixteen then. Her parents were visiting her uncle from capital at the time and left her to look after her younger sister Joan. In fact, she treated it like a punishnent. After all, she had better things to do, like going out with friends or something, but on the other hand, she hoped her parents would appreciate her Adult and Responsible Behavior. She never saw them again.

The attack took place at night. They didn't really feel the first effects. There was just no electricity at night. Water was still flowing from the tap, they couldn't hear explosions. Only in the morning, a friendly couple of neighbors knocked on their door and said that something terrible had happened in the capital of the planet, The Blackstone, and that the government had ordered an evacuation. But they didn't know anything specific. She woke up her sister and told her to pack. She had no idea where they were going, so she decided to go to the station. For a moment she considered visiting Gloria, her girlfriend at the time, and taking her with her, but then she decided that her mothers would take them to the country. They have their own all-terrain vehicle.

Besides, she had to take care of Joan. Her younger sister was terribly clumsy at times. She never saw Gloria again after that, had no idea what happened to her.

When they left the house, the first thing she saw were dark clouds hovering over their capital. She could see silhouettes of strange warships hovering over the city in the distance, but she couldn't observe them. Clouds obscured them… Only they weren't clouds, but smoke from burning houses. „We've been attacked” she thought in horror. Minitar was an isolated planet with a relatively small population, but they possessed enough forces to defend themselves from pirate attacks. Who could the invaders be? The Azlanti that have been talked about with fear for years? The Corpse Fleet she had been scared with since she was a child? She had no idea. *My parents were there* She felt sadness grip her heart.

She didn't stop any more, just ran to the train station, didn't let go of her sister's hand even for a moment. They quickly reached the station, where crowds of people, mostly parents with children, were already waiting. They did not take much belongings, only a few cans of food and bottles of water, and two blankets. They didn't even have enough supplies at home, no one was prepared for something like this. At first she was worried that she would look too grown up, that she would not be allowed to board and that she would have to let her sister go alone, but the carabineer at the entrance didn;t stopped her. He was not much older than her and looked like he wanted to join the rest of the passengers. It was cramped inside until she was suffocating. In front of her sat an old man holding the hand of a little boy, probably his grandson. Then the train started. She never saw her old home again and the town she grew up in adjacent to the capital. It probably wasn't destroyed, ironically, if they hadn't obeyed the command, the tragedy probably wouldn't have happened.

The journey took several hours. At some point, she began to feel overwhelming pressure on the bladder. Somehow she held out, but she felt that several children pis themselves. She had no idea where they were going. Minitar was a relatively recently colonized

world with less than fifty million inhabitants. Only the southern part of one of the three continents was inhabited. At first she thought they were going to Silverfall, the second largest city on the planet, but then it turned out they were going to the high mountains in the northeast. Now she understood that the major urban centers were the first targets of attack. Minitar, rich in resources, had an extensive railway network, but only one highway ran through the entire inhabited area, which they had passed long ago. Behind this piece of the window that they saw, she saw only an endless forest-steppe.

Most of the passengers were half-orcs and half-elves, the original colonizers of the planet, but there were many Aasimar and Tieflings. Minitar was supposed to be a planet for hybrids, their new home. Unfortunately, due to its remoteness from the other major planets, there has been little immigration here. All she heard was a familiar accent over the din of gossiping voices. They talked mainly about the attacker, what he wanted from them and whether someone would drive him away, because no one believed in the strength of the local military forces. Everyone thought it must have been the Azlanti. According to them, a planet full of hybrids must have been an abomination. However, in the end one of the passengers decided to turn on the long-range receiver. A spirited voice echoed in the carriage.

"Do not be afraid! Horde Prime has come here to bring His light to this darkened world. Your false leaders are dead or have fled in terror at the scale of their iniquity. But there is still hope for you. Humble yourself and submit to his judgment. You and your world will be transformed according to his will. Prime sees everything, Prime knows everything. Fear righteous judgment.

The message then looped. They listened to it for several minutes without saying anything, then someone shouted to turn it off. This was done immediately. There was silence for an hour or two. Then a few people started whispering that the invader was quite reasonable and that he couldn't be that bad. But to Dilayla, he sounded like a complete madman. She was afraid to think what someone like that might want from them. The Azlanti might have

been imperialist speciesists, but at least everyone knew they were reasonable and predictable to some degree. This someone seemed capable of absolutely anything.

They finally got there. It was a mountain town where wealthier citizens came to rest in the winter. Now they have been accommodated in hotels and sports halls. She and her sister got a bed and some food. Then they waited in silence. Joan had always been a quiet and slightly clumsy kid. Now she had withdrawn into herself, but at least she was obeying orders. Several people tried to turn on radios and other receivers, but received the same eerie messages.

In the morning, a message from the Elder, the speaker of parliament, was broadcast from the cars through loudspeakers, informing them that the army was putting up a valiant resistance to the enemy. But no one really believed it. There were rumors that the Capital and Silverfall had been taken, that the attacker was an AI, or that they were white demons from the Ravaged Zone. It was said that temples were attacked with particular ferocity and that mystics were killed on the spot. Nobody knew anything for sure.

Now, after all these years of fighting, she knew that the enemy had simply moved his forces to the other side of the continent to avoid the enemy's fortified positions. The first explosions were heard in the night. Donor station destroyed. She and her sister ran outside and saw the same alien ships in the sky as before. They also saw the real enemy. Walking machines of various kinds were moving towards the few defending soldiers. She saw them too, White Demons. They didn't really look that scary. Tall white figures slipped under the defenders' fire, knocking them down with well-aimed shots. She turned and saw Joan kneeling by some crying litle girl.

"Joan, we have to run." She grabbed her sister by the shoulder.

"But we can't leave her here." Joan said, staring at her with her over-mature eyes. The baby was cowering and no one was

around. They can't leave her.

"What is your name?" she asked, barely controlling her terror.

"I'm Asin," she turned a tearful face to her.

"I'm Dilayla and this is my sister Joan. Now we're going to run, run as fast as we can." she said and stood up

They moved forward. She just didn't know where. They had to stay away from the attacker. Farther from death. She tried to run crouched. Some people tried to seek shelter in the cellars, while others tried to get out of the combat zone. She saw her one of the ships fired a green beam that hit temple of Desna. Many refugees, including children, found shelter there. They had to be far away or they too would suffer the same fate.

They came to a bridge where the army was trying to make some sort of barricade out of a couple of vehicles and sandbags. It was futile, but it stopped many civilians from escaping. Now she knew that the commander was as much an idiot as he was a warcriminal who had killed many innocents with his senseless stubbornness. She took the girl in her arms and turned into a side street. There were a lot less people here, maybe they'll make it.

Then they saw the enemy, the detachment circled the city, separating the people hiding there from the shelter of the mountain forests. Several different kinds of droids and two aliens. She threw herself into the bushes growing in the nearby yard, but Joan stumbled and one of the droids noticed her. He fired a warning shot, and all three froze in horror. One of the soldiers moved towards them. He slowly walked over to Joan and aimed the gun at her, but hesitated.

"It's a waste of Horde Prima resources. Mercy was shown to you…" he turned sharply. She looked in that direction. New ships appeared in the sky. Black purple with sharp edges. Their appearance must have been terrifying even to unsuspecting people, but she knew what fleet they belonged to.

Hellknights, gods... she thought. At that moment, she took it for granted that they had come to support the invaders. They were chsracters of countless tales about the crimes they committed in the name of absolute order... Allies of the devils who carried the fire of hell where they saw iniquity.
But then the ships of the hellknights opened fire on the ships of the invanders.

The alien turned and looked back, and she grabbed her sister's hand, and they started to run again, No one paid any attention to them now.
He ran to the side, trying to somehow slip between the planetary defense and the invaders. She didn't think, she was too scared to think. She couldn't feel the girl's weight. Adrenaline was pumping too much through her veins.

Finally, after long minutes, they managed to get out of the battlefield. The city was on fire, and so were the skies where the ships clashed. Again she heard the sounds of the war machines, so the three of them hid in a drainage ditch. She began to pray to all the gods she knew that no one would hurt them this time. The girl had pee herself long ago, soiling Dilayla's clothes.

She heard an inhuman roar, and then she felt herself losing control of her own bladder. She lifted her head and saw a monster coming out of the nearby forest. On six metal insect legs rose a corpus that made one think of a monstrous knight with a burning body. He held a huge trident in one hand and a steel net with hooks in the other. A second creature soon appeared, and red laser beams shot from the tridents. She heard an explosion and fragments of some droid flew past her. Then the infernal beasts charged. She clung to the ground, certain that they would be trampled by creatures from hell. However, by a miraculous twist of fate, they ran over the three of them. She heard the sounds of fighting, and the other shouts, much more human this time.
The clash didn't last long. Even such a ruthless opponent was not ready to face the unleashed fury of hell. Soon the soldiers moved on, with exception of one.

He heard heavy metal footsteps approaching them.

"Please spare us." she moaned with difficulty.

"I'm not going to hurt you, but you need to get out of here as soon as possible." she heard a strong but surprisingly ordinary voice. She turned to see the hellknight towering over her. He had an eclipse sun sign on his chest. In one hand he held a morningstar. With some hesitation, she got up and told her sister to do the same.

"Go that way. I have already informed my people that you are here…" He did not finish because they heard a powerful explosion. One of the attackers' ships was hit and taxi towards them. The knight looked at them and, after a short hesitation, jumped to cover the girl. Dilayla curled up and covered her head with her hands. Then she heard her sister scream, drowned out by the sound of the explosion

The first thing she saw was a sword. A sword surrounded by a golden solar rim. It was around the doctor's neck of android.

"Calm down, don't get up. You've been through a lot." he said in a calm, gentle voice.

"Where am I? What happened to me?" she asked. Her throat hurt, she felt as if she had swallowed gravel.

"You survived the ship's explosion, but you were seriously injured. You are in the hospital in Ironhill, on your planet.|

Memories slowly came back to her. She rose sharply.

"Where's my sister…" she called and looked at her hand. It was made of metal, cybernetical.

"Your arms and leg suffered enough damage that it was decided that it would be easier to amputate them and replace them with cybernetic prostheses, similarly your hearing was saved ... As for your sister, the knight Janos di Vir ordered to give her the best

medical care and ... She survived, but her the damage was much more extensive, and there wasn't much biological tissue left, but after a long period of rehabilitation, she would function almost as before."

Almost like before she thought.

"What about the invaders?" did we win? She asked feeling tears welling up in her eyes.

"Yes, the enemy retreated, although almost a hundred thousand inhabitants of your planet died. The Order says it was the Dominion of Black." the doctor explained slowly.
But who is Horde Prime... she thought as she felt a dull throbbing pain throbbing throughout her body.

"What will become of us now?" she asked resignedly.

"As far as I know, the Order will take care of you." said the android.

In fact, that's what happened. She had been under the protection of the Order of Eclipse for four years, but refused to join it. She couldn't accept the lies they were telling. She has been a mercenary for thirty years, training until the day she meets hert foe again.

She met her sister only once after that. She wouldn't recognize her, not only from her appearance, but also from her behavior... Both of them were then born again. With that scream.

***
Writing this chapter was extremely slow, but here it is!

The Huntress, The Warlock and The Lictor.

Rehiza walked next to Miss Daisy, trying not to look in her direction, but the presence of the grim elf was like a thorn in the heel. "This woman is hiding something, something very dark, and I have sworn to stand against the darkness." But only what. In her opinion, Lady Cala was above all suspicion. A polite but not submissive aristocrat from a peripheral planet, raised from childhood to exercise power and lead people. At first she thought she might be the source of future trouble, and had even intended to go to Carurystal to find out more, but she ran out of time. Miss Daisy was not what she expected. an educated, but rather down-to-earth teacher of a highborn woman, and what she met was a person who emanated an aura of powerful magical power…and darkness. She also hid her face behind a holographic mask, and that never boded well. Not in that combination…

The streets of Saltmarsh were narrow and dusty, but oddly enough paved, They walked side by side for a long time in silence. It was quite crowded, the inhabitants of the capital tried to make it before the evening flight of flies. Miss Daisy walked confidently forward, and the passers-by yielded to her without a murmur. It came incredibly naturally to her, even the tall Vesk nomads kept out of her way. It wasn't what she expected from someone like that either.

"And how do you like Saltmarsh?" She finally asked, trying to smile with interest.

"Dusty, dirty hot... could be worse. But I've gotten used to the rain and the green of Carurystal, and I like it better," replied the grim Elf.

"Very different from where you come from?" Miss Daisy watched intently, but she didn't even slow down.

"What place are you talking about? Carurystal or my home planet? In both cases, the answer will be yes." the teacher replied sharply.

"Actually, where are you from? - Lashunti tried to keep her voice as gentle as possible.
"From Latroxia, but you probably know that, you finally had my dossier." She stopped and turned to the Lashunti, looking at her with her piercing green eyes.

"Yes, it's a peripheral planet, isolated from the rest of the galaxy, inhabited by Castroval Elves who wanted to preserve their thousand-year-old culture and tradition. They reject most of advanced technology. Little else is known, only a few are allowed to visit it, and even fewer leave it. In a word, an extremely mysterious place. Perfect for someone who wants to hide their true origin." Rechiza said with a mocking smile. Miss Daisy answered her with a similar smile.

"Yes, very convenient. To be honest, it absolutely doesn't matter what you think of me, any more than what I think of you. We both serve persons far greater than ourselves."

Rechiza frowned. *What does she know?*

"I serve the Lord Admiral and you Lady Cala, I don't think you mean anything else." she said without changing her expression.

"Indeed, and how could it be otherwise?" said elf and moved forward.

A few weeks earlier, Rechiza had entered the office of Liktor Janos di Vir. She stayed on the Dreadnought-citadel "Fading Sun", flagship of the Order. It was gloomy here, only a few lamps that perfectly imitated the light of torches illuminated the darkness of this room.

"I welcome you Rechiza, it's good that you arived so quickly" said the man with ebony skin, sitting behind a semi-circular red desk. His face was dotted with deep lines and numerous scars. Still, he

exuded great strength. It was said that he once knocked down a Hezrou during a fight and survived an encounter with Marlith

"It is not proper to delay when Liktor summons you." she bowed politely

"But you are not a member of the Order, though you are willing to cooperate with us. I have a task for you this time as well. he said and stood up, then turned his back on her.

"You were summoned here because of events that took place more than thirty years ago. Then the planet Minitar was attacked by an unknown enemy. It easily overcame the local, not very strong, defense, and would probably have subdued it if we hadn't been around. It wasn't an easy fight. We had to call for help from our dark allies, and only then could we prevail. I was then only a young knight who took part in this short war. Without false modesty, I will say that I showed great courage at that time, which was appreciated. But I'm most proud of the lives I've saved. One of them belonged to a little girl named Asindesa." he turned sharply to her. "My adopted daughter."

"And the current Lady of Blades." Lashunt asked quietly

Likor nodded and continued.

"She made a real career in the order. She fought for many years in the wars we fought. She became the embodiment of what is good in us, trying not to be infected by the darkness we carry. She faced the Swarm and the cultists, the most feared enemies you can meet. Now, however, he is going on a journey deep into the Ravaged Zone. And there she will meet those who attacked her planet.

Rechiza, stony-faced, listened to Liktor's word. While she disliked the ideas behind the hellknights, she respected Liktor and their goals often coincided.

"It is said there's a Swarm operating there?" she asked genuinely surprised. Janos di Vir nodded.

"That's what everyone says, but according to our information, it's not true. There is something different lurking there, though perhaps not so much. When we won at Minitar, we decided not to reveal what we know for now. It could cause chaos in the galaxy.

"And the Order can't afford that." she smiled understandingly. "But now there were problems."

"It's more complicated. said Janos di Vir and told her about mysterious event and the plans to send The Research and Exploration Fleet.

She frowned as she slowly processed his words.

"So you think someone initiated the use of this weapon, and twice, but both times it didn't unleash its full power? You're implying they where the same beings that attacked Minitar."

The Lictor shrugged.

"Or it was used by someone who was defending themselves from them. We don't know anything for sure, so we'll send a small group of people ahead of us to find out what it really was like and what lurks there."

"And I'm supposed to be in that group? Do you suspect the activities of cults and Great Old Ones?" she asked with a sigh. *It's a matter for a pirate or someone from Starfinder society*

"Yes, we suspect everything and everyone. There is one more thing. As I mentioned, Lady Cala will be participating in the mission. I recently learned that Asindesa visited Castle Grayskull, Cala’s ancestral seat on Carurystal, and was seriously injured there. However, during our last meeting, my daughter did not tell me anything about it."

"Do you want me to keep an eye on Lady Cala? she asked matter-of-factly. It was more suited to her abilities."

:"Yes. Just remember, this whole trip smells bad to me." said the lictor very seriously.

The Lashunti nodded, then asked.

"Ansindesa knows about these beings?" That they attacked her house" she asked, looking at Janos carefully.

"Yes, I told her during our last meeting." he gave her the datacore "Here you have all the information we managed to gather about the enemy. And remember…

"Yes, I know, trust no one." she smiled sourly. *Do you think why I'm still alive?*

Regaining her sense of smell was perhaps the most unobvious profit of what the Nyarlathetop had done to her. Over the decades of inhaling toxic fumes from factories or mystical decoctions, and several dark rituals and even a few less-than-successful experiments by Hordak, she had lost that sense. Now she felt the fullness of the flavors of the food she ate and the aromas of the teas she drank. She even accepted the stench, because the lack of a sense, even a relatively unimportant one, could exhaust mentally, distorted her perception of reality.

How did she last there? With her keen sense of smell, the stench of the zone must have been unbearable to her. Or was she just used to it since she was a child? You can get used to anything. I know something about this. she thought as she walked beside Lashuntka. She knew she should focus on her companion, but her thoughts wandered to her dark past and the future she feared so much.

And Rosie? What's it like to live in perpetual silence? she thought. It is likely that her hearing also suffered some damage during her previous life. The girl was surprisingly nice and positive about the world. *If she had been cared for by someone like me… would she*

see so much good in others then? she smiled grimly. Rechiza looked at her, frowning.

Something amused you? she asked rather sharply.

"No. I've never been a laughing person. The last time I smiled serenely was five years ago. Usually, when I smile, it means I have thought something very unpleasant." she said without looking at the Witchwarper.

"Unpleasant for you or for other?" Lashunti asked with amusement.
She smiled in response.

The Respite was in the center of the city, between the market and the spaceport. It did not fit into the local style of architecture. It looked surprisingly "Modern" and "Normal", although to her none of the buildings she encountered outside of her former home looked "Normal". Even the conservative architecture of Carurystal seemed strange and very different from what she was used to. On the other hand, she didn't travel much in her own world. Only in the last five years has she been able to fully experience the countless variety of cultures that could be born in an infinite universe. Though I'd rather not start exploring the wonders of the universe of waking up on cursed Aucturn before face of Nyarlathetop's avatar.

As they entered, she smelled tea. She liked that aroma. The interior was kept in cool colors. The gray walls were slightly shiny, and the tables were black and made of what was supposed to be wood, but was probably some kind of plastic. The main hall was hexagonal in shape. They sat down at the table and looked around. There were a few people who looked like local bourgeoisie and wealthy Shiren farmers. There were also a few Vesks who were clad in rather costly robes and a bit too ornate weapons. They ordered Ashrak

"Does anyone here look like a space ship's captain to you?" she asked, sinking into a chair. Even such a short walk in the desert

sun could be surprisingly tiring.

"Not really, and for you?" Lashuti asked.

"I used to know a captain... And he wasn't a man you would want to travel anywhere with." she murmured, "Unless you like fire."

Ashrak has been brought. The drink was slightly tart, with a rather strongly perceptible aroma somewhat reminiscent of cucumbers. It was quite invigorating.

"Because of this man you have to wear a holographic mask?" Lashunti asked innocently.

"I should replace it. No, that's not why. "she said, and immediately regretted her honesty.

"So it's some kind of failed ritual." Rechiza asked over a cup of tea.

She wondered how to answer her and how much honesty she could afford, and whar that woman might know about the darkness with which she had made a pact.

"Oh, someone said something about a magical accident!" They heard an enthusiastic exclamation and turned around at the same time. They saw a dark-skinned elf with silvery hair. She wore a fairly typical wizard's robe with bare shoulders. Elf was smiling extremely enthusiastically. She had a bad experience with similarly smiling people. Silverhaired sat down at their table without asking and began to talk.

"I am Ireanis Toromach called the Silver Flame! Battlemage from Nantambu on lost Golarion! Dwarf tea!" exclaimed the elf and went back to the conversation "Unfortunately, the spell didn't quite work out and somehow it turned out that it threw me at Kesler just when they had a problem with ants or some kind of swarm and actually I was a bit lost in time because I was thrown some thousand years ahead and a thousand kilometers from Mwengi. But Bina and Igzar saved me. I mean Igzar threatened to

throw me out the airlock if I started doing magic, but he was such a prankster. He probably wouldn't do anything to me. And then we were on Atraks and then we lived on Akiton and we traveled through this space for a long time because we have a spaceship and by the way, I work as a teacher teaching ..." - she was saying, but Rechiza interrupted her.

"Wait, repeat what you said again?"
"That I'm a teacher and a magic officer, but back to…" she continued, but this time Miss Daisy didn't let her go on.

"There is absolutely no doubt that you consider yourself an excellent teacher, but we are interested in the ship you traveled on. How is he."

"Metal. And cosmic." Ireanis replied smiling broadly. Rechiza pursed her lips, thinking the elf to make fun of her or be an idiot. Well, to her, spaceships meant nothing but metal and space. And if this woman is from Lost Golarion…

"Where are you flying to and do you have seats available?" she asked slowly.

The dark-skinned elf confused was suddenly.

"Well, if you ask, we're going to one place ... But we have free quarters for passengers, only about that, you have to ask Bina." Tea has just been brought to Ireanis. She took a sip and winced.

"But there's no rum here? What's a dwarf tea without rum! How am I supposed to do magic sober!" cried the elf.

This can be a really long conversation. She thought and turned to the silver-haired girl, trying to focus her attention.

"And where is Bina?" *How did Catra put up with those two for so long?*

Ireanis looked around in surprise.

"She was here somewhere. BINA!!!" She stood up and screamed across the room.

"Do you think what I think? That they are flying…" Lashunti asked. She nodded her head.

The silver-haired elf approached a woman who was talking to several expensively dressed Vesks. When Ireanis slapped her on the back, and she reached for her gun, the heavy pistol hanging from her belt. Then elf gestured ridiculously and pointed them. Finally, "Bina" got up and walked over to them, taking a seat at the chair that Ireanis had previously occupied.

"Hiya. I am Bina. You were talking with my friend and she claims that you said something about spaceships and if we had seats ..." asked the woman smiling friendly. She was quite petite, had burgundy hair and seemed to be quite a cheerful person, although she had dark circles under her eyes, probably from lack of sleep.

"Yes, we need a ship... The problem is where we're going." she said slowly, looking at the woman carefully.

"Yes? The galaxy is immeasurable, full of terrible places" Bina replied cautiously. She tensed, and moved her hand towards the weapon.

"You're right, we're headed there."Rechiza said. She also looked ready to fight.

?Oh yes. It's a funny coincidence... So many people suddenly want to go to such a scary place." the burgundy-haired woman said slowly. Ireanis stood behind her. She no longer looked as harmlessly stupid as before.

It was much scarier place than you can imagine. Although now ... we know so litle she thought

"And indeed, it seems that we are all heading in the same direction, which makes our goals seem to converge. There were times when I worked with people with whom I had little else in

common, and I always performed my duties well. My companion, as far as I know, is a specialist in fighting dark creatures, I ... apart from being a gifted sor ... Mystic, valued teacher and great expert in the art of gardening, I am also the guardian and steward of Lady Cala Grayskull." she said calmly, analyzing her interlocutor and her reactions to her words.

"Besides, it accompanies us Arkan-tar, the archaeologist. Doctor Qin, Dilayla as our bodyguard and Rosie Pearl. intern. We're going to the so-called Ravaged Zone, and so are you. We are part of an expedition organized by Kemanis University. We are financed by Lady Cala Grayskull, in exchange for on profits from any treasures we find there. Lashunti said.

"Aren't you afraid of what lurks in the Zone?" Bina asked, raising an eyebrow.

We all know that something happened there and since then this place has changed and it's not so dangerous anymore - she replied - Otherwise you wouldn't go there yourself.

Bina smiled quite warmly.

"Good point." she thought about it and continued "You know, we are actually also participating in an archaeological expedition, such a self-organized one. And we could use a doctor, a teacher, and an archaeologist. Listen, I'll show you our ship, and if you will like it, and my crew will like you, maybe we'll pick you up for a small fee."

"All right, we'll visit you in the evening, give me the coordinates" Rechiza asked, and the burgundy-haired girl gave them and left her the coordinates.

"Well, hello, see you tonight." she said and walked away with Ireanis.

"We did it pretty fast, don't you think?"Rechiza asked a bit surprised.

"Indeed... she replied thoughtfully.

"And you're not surprised that she's glad she found a teacher?" Rechiza asked her

"No... It's definitely not that..." she looked at her anxiously.

Save the Bot

"Well, we fly anyway, unless we land somewhere, then we just walk around and beat things. Sometimes we set something on fire, sometimes we beat someone up, but usually we don't bring death and destruction, unless we do, but that rarely happens because Bina gets angry, and she gets angry a lot, especially when she talks to Itel because they argue all the time, usually when Bina wants us not to do something and Itel wants us to do something and it's the same thing or vice versa and sometimes Eti also annoys Bina when she is too much Eti but Eti sometimes annoys Itel and they argue even though Itel likes Eti a lot but probably not like Eti likes Itel, and Alatar argue with Eti and tease each other, but usually only by talking, because if they needeled each other they will be bleed, and they know when stop, otherwise Alatar will breathe fire, and the Eti will shoot unless he strikes. And I like chocolate, see?"

Wrongdak smiling slowly shook his head.

" I don't understand you at all, but its fine. I don’t understand half of what my friend is saying to. But I like listening to her. Not many are patient enough to let her say everything she has to say, and only my older brother seems to really understand what she is saying." Wrongdak said with a friendly smile.

"That’s… good." Lilka said with satisfaction in her voice. Itel sighed heavily. She wasn't sure if Lilce really cared if anyone was listening to her. She had the impression that her friend simply did not like the silence that now prevailed. They were on the outskirts of Saltmarsh, if that godsforsaken hole could be compared to a city. There were only a few houses surrounded by low walls and parking lots, mostly empty, and warehouses. Many buildings looked unfinished, as if the builders lacked motivation. Saltmarsh was considered an abandoned planet where mostly the desperate lived.

What can they know about abandonment. They have the whole globe to themselves. We Kesler orphans have nothing, not even ashes. She clenched her fists. She summoned and recalled the blade, trying to calm down.

"Is Itel going to fight someone?" asked the strange alien they had freed.

"No, she does that when she's pissed off or thinking hard about something." Lilka replied, tilting her head.

"And now?" Wrongdak stared at the Elf's back.

"Well, I'm not sure ..." the redhead folded her hands and cried out "Itel, are you pissed or are you thinking hard?!"

The Solarian looked up and turned to the others.

" I'm trying to think hard about something but you won't let me so I'm pissed, happy!?" she screamed.

"
"Don't worry, sometimes she just has to argue with someone and Bina is not around. said Alatar in a bored voice staring at his datapad. She hoped he was studying a map of the city or looking for objects to hack, not playing silly games. She turned back in the direction they were going and asked on the comm

"Eti, do you see anything?"
"I have pretty good eyesight. Although, considering I hadn't eaten anything this morning, and I haven't had a piece of meat in my mouth for TWO weeks, I should be going blind by now." the Scout complained

Itel took a deep breath.

"You know what I'm asking!"
"No I do not know. You could learn to express yourself with precision instead of expecting me to develop telepathy. I know I'm

absolutely perfect, awesome and unique, but I haven't developed any psionic talents yet." her friend's voice was as calm as ever.

"I'm asking if you haven't seen any dangers!" the solarian said, clearly emphasizing each word.

"If you are asking about that, no i haven’t see nany dangers. Though some birds bother me." said their scout.

"Leave the birds alone!" she snapped at her friend.

"As long as they leave me alone." Eti replied with a threat in her voice.

Itel screamed and turned off her communicator.

"Let's go!" she ordered without turning around.

"I'm beginning to understand what you were telling me." Wrongdak said after a moment's thought.

Lilka nodded at him.

Itel was annoyed. For many reasons. She didn't like this planet. She hoped to find some useful information about their destination here. After all, this place was on the edge of the most mysterious corner of the known universe. There should be some clues here. They found… She turned and looked at their new companion. … Him. The Wrongdak belonged to species she had never heard of, but there were plenty of creatures in the galaxy she had never heard of. Only she had serious doubts that he could be one of those legendary White Demons. She looked over her shoulder at him. He was tall and white, the latter was obvious. He had light pink eyes with no pupils or irises, large bat ears, and no nose. His hair was braided in dreadlocks, dyed in various bright colors. He was wearing an oversized multi-colored shirt, one of those Skittermanderers would invent for the Vesks, one that no self-respecting citizen of Veskarium would ever wear. If you deduct the skittermander embellishments, he could hardly pass for one of the White Demons ... But his character was completely didn’t fit. He

was friendly, curious about the world and probably if it wasn't for the problem with Emily, he would be quite cheerful. Exactly, Emily…. They were supposed to look for her in the junkyard… That meant that Wrongdak's friend was most likely dead. It is why someone was sent to the junkyard. Now she's probably lying in some crushed wreckage, crushed, unrecognizable. She didn't know how their new companion would behave when he saw what fate befell his friend. Of course, she will have to tell him the tragic news, because who else? Lilka and Alatar can't put such things into words, they'll probably cry themselves. And Eti could have put it into words all too well. She could talk about gruesome things and the time of normal conversation without batting an eyelid. It's easy to imagine how Wrongdak would feel if she described to him in detail the appearance of Emily's mangled corpse ... But Eti could be insensitive, mean and lacking in empathy. And also, *Is Emily pretty?*, she asked so openly and without hesitation! *Well, it sure not anymore* she thought wryly.

The junkyard was located on the very outskirts of the city. Beyond that was the only fusion power plant that provided power for the city and probably half the planet. The junkyard was actually sort of a multiple-recycling facility here. In a place like this, everyhing that could be repaired, even if it would later dangle on duct tape, was reused. The great square was surrounded by a high wall with barbed wire placed on it. The gates were remotely slided open. To the left of them, there was a camera in front of which anyone who wanted to enter had to stand. Itel stood some distance away and ordered the others to do the same.

"Eti, there are any security?" she asked her friend.

"Maybe." their scout replied coldly. *Oh, now she's offended*

"Eti, why don't we put it off until later? We don't have time for your sulks!"she said slowly, trying not to explode with rage.

"Sulks?! My sulks?! I'm sorry, but who hung up on me and didn't talk to me for a whole quarter of an hour, and a few hours earlier you blamed me for not talking. So tell me my dear how it is. I'm

only supposed to talk when you like it, right?" the shooter asked over the communicator with barely a hint of annoyance.

"Then don't jump out with your hunting paranoia, because you know how you sound ... Like a cat!" Itel screamed. This time it was Eti who turned off the communicator. She turned to see Alatar, Lika and Wrongdak kneeling in a circle on the mismatched and cracked concrete slabs that made up the roadway.

"It's going to take a while for them to argue." We're sorry you have to watch this. he said, embarrassed.

"Is not so bad. My friends had a argue once, and one of them basically blew up the planet, but they made up and they're friends." Wrongdak said with a reassuring smile. Alatar and Lilka stared at him for a long moment.

"I don't want to meet your friends." Dragonkin said carefully. Lilka nodded vigorously.

"And for me, blowing up a planet is an extremely funny punchline."said Eti from the roof of the building, probably some abandoned warehouse, where suspicious individuals were probably hiding at night. The scout began to waked down parade style the vertical wall and approached them. She stood in front of Itel and saluted derisively.

"Senior scout Eterna reports to Captain Itel that the order has been carried out." she said in the tone of a soldier addressing a commander. Itel clenched her teeth in fury.

"Are you kidding me!" The green-haired elf screamed.

Eti tilted her head to the side, resting it on her shoulder.

"Sure. If you can't act like an adult. - Eti said, but before the Solarian could answer, the scout continued." There are four guard bots in the junkyard that appear to be made by the owner. It is Shiren technician, quite competent looking. He employs two Damai, I think sisters, quite pretty, but also dangerous looking. I

cut the wire in one place, but Alatar will have to hack into their system.

Itel didn't even comment on the bit about the pretty sisters, she just turned to Alatar

"Can you do it?"

The silver dragonkin nodded.

"It shouldn't be difficult. I just need to get closer." he murmured uncertainly.

"You will fly, just like me and Lilka will climb the rope." she said, and Alatar sighed.

"A little exercise won't hurt you, drako." Eti said, the technomancer gave her an offended look.

"I'll go on the rope too. Emily is my friend, I have to help her." Wrongdak said with emotion. "My brother and my friends entrusted me with the task of looking after her. We went to the stars to prove that He lied, that He was not the ruler of the known universe. He... Horde Prime was a liar! But… I failed my friends! I failed Emily... I have to save her. She's my friend too... We were together on Vesk III and had many wonderful adventures there. I wouldn't forgive myself if something happened to her. I will go and help you." he had a tight mouth.

Itel winced and groaned. *If he goes with them, he will surely see her friend's corpse... He won't survive this encounter.*

"You know... It's going to be a serious fight against a real opponent, you understand?" And maybe something will happen to you... "She tried to explain it calmly and slowly, just like Bina did when she was explaining to Lilka that she couldn't fight with a land shark in the arena.

"I can handle it. I'm a born soldier, although I don't like to fight… But for Emily, I will not hesitate to face ten Skitterwanders." he

said with great confidence.
Yes, of course she sighed, seeing that it was a hopeless case. "All right, let's go!" she called and summoned the moonblade, then pointed towards the junkyard.

Eti turned to their new companion.
"Just one question, is Emily a lady?"

"Of course! She is a very great lady!" Wrongdak exclaimed excitedly, and Eti scolded with a soft "perfect"

"I've always wanted to save a damsel in distress." Eti said with almost palpable joy in her voice.

One more word Itel thought, and with murder in her eyes, she moved forward.

Eti stalked in the shadows and was almost content with her life. The whole day had been great. First, she had obtained the crucial and necessary information, and then she had been instrumental in saving Wormdak. She was practically the pillar of their little scuad. And most importantly, she's going to rescue a beautiful and noble lady... She'll be a true hero... Not what she told her to be... She took a deep breath and leaned against the wall. *Calm down, you're close to creating a storm, and storm days haven't been good. Especially so soon after rainy days…* She raised her google and pressed her fingers to her eyes. She felt the hardness of the surprisingly warm metal and the smoothness of a leather glove. She pressed so hard that the protective sponge crumpled and she felt an unpleasant pressure on the tips of her fingers where claws had once been. “I shouldn't mean to Itel. She's my friend and all. That's right, buddy.” She took the braid in her archaeotechnical hand and wrapped it around it. She'd have to apologize to her somehow, but she wasn't good at talking about feelings… How could she talk about them if she didn't even fully understand them. She wanted to go to the ship and pet Toshi, but she had to help her friends, didn't she? Taking a deep breath, she climbed onto the water tank, picked it up, and held the telescope to her eye. She had a view of most of the junkyard area.

"How are you getting in?"she asked her friends.

"Alatar is breaking security right now." Itel told her.

Eti looked around and saw a dragonkin balancing on the wall. She nodded and looked around for the guards. She saw three of them. Two patrolled the area along the walls. They were relatively small and somewhat coarse. It had four spindly legs and a cylindrical head with two electric cannons. The third was standing by the workshop. The body was square, slightly blocky. It had two broad legs and on the sides it had two guns firing pellets. She decided to take care of the big one first, because the small ones have a limited range, and if necessary, she'll take them out in one shot anyway. This one will be a more difficult target and prefers to focus on it. Especially since he was guarding the owner of the entire property, a tall Shiren in a helmet with holes for antennas. He carried a heavy metal cane and wore decent work clothes. Beside him stood Damai with a shotgun and dressed in similar work clothes. They were both studying some strange spherical bot trapped on the repair ramp. It had one purple eye and three legs. It was painted in bright colors, somewhat Skittermander style. Eti thought for a moment and then turned to Itel via communicator.

"Ask Wormdak if Emily has three legs."

"What?" Itel asked, clearly disbelieving her.

"Just ask him. " Eti said impatiently. *It was a simple and obvious question*!

"Yep, she has three legs" Itel said in surprise.

"Then tell Wormdak she's safe and sound."Eti replied.

A robot, not a robot, counts as a lady.

Wrongdak felt relief spread throughout his body. He didn't feel that way even after death of Him. Then his heart was flooded with sadness mixed with fear, although it was only a shadow of what

his brothers experienced. He was just calm now. He knew somehow they would manage to save his friend. His new friends looked brave and resourceful, if a little scary.

"Give me any weapons, I'll be really useful to you." he asked the elf. She looked at him skeptically.

"But it will be very dangerous, you may get hurt.- Itel spoke slowly, as if she was addressing a child or someone who did not understand what she was saying. He was used to the fact that most beings outside the empire did not see him for who he was - an artificially created soldier whose meaning of existence was to fight and die for Him... He came into this world trained better than Vesk warriors. However, he had no idea about many even the most basic things, and for this reason many thought him dumb.

"I'll be fine, trust me." he said with a friendly smile, but then Itel bristled. She narrowed her eyes and nodded sharply.

"You won't get any weapons, over my dead body!" And she turned her back on him. It wasn't a problem. He could also fight hand to hand and was really good at it.

Itel lurked behind a pile of scrap metal, signaled them to stay in wait. He felt someone tugging at his sleeve. He turned to see Lilka, who signaled him to be quiet by putting her finger to her lips and making a loud "Szzzz", then pointed to a gas tube sticking out of a pile of scrap metal. He understood what she meant.

"Trust is not Itel's strong point." said Lilka in a whisper as he reached for the iron. He grabbed the tube and pulled hard. As soon as he pulled it out, the whole pile of scrap metal tumbled onto the cobblestones. Itel shot him an angry look and went to fight.

In Eti's opinion, the idea of collapsing a pile of scrap metal was as effective as it was uncomfortably loud, at least for her sensitive hearing. Without waiting for the thud to stop, she found the boxy robot and aimed hers rifle at it. As she fired, a ball of

incandescent plasma hit the target. The hit damaged the weapon, rendering it unusable. She fired twice in a flash, aiming at the legs of the machine. Then she intended to find and destroy the two smaller robots, but with her keen hearing she heard someone trying to climb onto the reservoir. *Ah, second sister, I almost forgot* She saw that the second Damai had just climbed up. She put her arm above the ladder and shot at Eti, who, however, deftly dodged and jumped towards her, then jumped down grabbing the junkyard worker's sleeve and dragging her down. The scout landed on her knees bent, and her opponent hit the hard cobblestones with a groan. But then she felt movement behind her. She dodged to the side and saw the last robot, the one she had completely forgotten about. He had legs with inverted knees like those of a dinosaur and a long jaw capable of crushing bones. A homemade version of the popular pest control robot. She hit him twice with the butt like a mace, but only pushed him away. So she shifted the rifle to her left hand and clenched her metal fist. She took a wide swing and hit the machine with all her strength, releasing all the power contained in her hand. The metal flashed blindingly, and the ancient symbols became visible to all for a moment. Energy flowed through the metal body, tearing it into tiny pieces. She walked away from the wreckage of the machine and walked over to Damai and put her boot on her back, then hit her head with her now half-inert arm. Her opponent lost consciousness and Etti slowly made her way to the square in front of the workshop. Her companions were safe and sound, except for Lilka, whose hair was sticking out in all directions. Itel was already taking a deep breath to yell at her, but when she saw her hand hanging limply by her side, she softened. That explained a lot. Wormdak stood over the remains of one of the bots, holding a gas-tube in his hand, and pointed at Emily. He looked quite menacing now. Alatar simply walked over to the repair ramp mechanism and freed the robot. Emily immediately ran to Wormdak and he hugged her. They stayed like that for a while. Eti looked at the wreckage. She managed to disable the robot, Damaj was cowering with a wound in her side, and Shiren was holding his maimed hand.

"It's my droid, what right do you have to steal from me!" Shiren exclaimed indignantly.

"Technically, while Emily is not a beautiful and curvaceous lady, she is a fully self-aware entity and as such cannot be traded. What you were doing falls under the slave trade, which is punishable on the pact worlds from twenty years in prison to life sentence in a penal colony." Alatar said. The junkyard owner clicked a few times in annoyance, but said nothing more.

"Well, we did quite well. And you fight really well Wrongdak, where did you learn that?" Itel asked with appreciation in her voice. Wrongdak stood up and smiled brightly.

"I did not study anywhere ... I was created to do this. I'm a clone." he said, as if confessing some shameful secret. Itel nodded, but Eti walked over to Emily. The bot chattered at the sight of her as she knelt before him. The ranger saw that there were claw marks on the front of the body. With a bad feeling, she placed her left hand against them. They fit the heck out of it.

No. She was never there. She is a lie. a fraud she stood up abruptly, pushing Emily away from her.

"Did something happen?" Wordak asked anxiously.

"I don't like your bot. But you won't understand it. You're just a clone, a poor and pathetic imitation of the original that will never be anything real. - she said, aware that she had probably hurt him. She pulled up her hood and walked forward.

Shadow of the Past - Archduke's Ball.

She woke up

The carriage, drawn by mechanical horses, had just come to an abrupt halt.

"We're here, Miss Daisy." Leris said in an excited voice.

She thought it was strange, because girl would spend the entire party in the servants quarters anyway. Although this celebration was so great that even the servants could taste the most wonderful dishes and drinks. Maybe they'll actually have more fun here. People like her, representatives of the aristocracy, to which theoreticaly she belonged,, had much more interesting things to do here. She stood on the step as she stepped out of the carriage and winced at the smell of the city air. It reminded her of the old days when she had lived in the Fright Zone contaminated and poisoned with toxic fumes. Lynortis numbered a million souls and was five times as many as her's old *home*. The capital of Carurystal was an ancient city built during the Gap, though many scholars have argued that some of the artifacts and ruins may have been much older. The happiest part of her life had been spent among ancient buildings with dark secrets, so Lynortis felt almost like home. *But did I ever have a home, a place where I felt safe and loved?* she smiled grimly to herself.

She looked at the Archduke's palace. The building was magnificent, although it did not overwhelm with its majesty. The Lord of Carurystal was not a dictator or a living god walking the earth, but the first among equals. It reminded her of happier times too, a life she had so easily spurned. "Why do I feel so nostalgic for the old days? What has been will not return ... " She thought as she felt a cold sweat pour over her. "History likes to repeat itself, but only as a farce, they say. But in my case, it's a grotesque tragicomedy, nothing more" she thought, looking at the marble slabs beneath her feet. And she almost ran into Prince

Henoh, one of the sons of the Archduke. But he just nodded politely and walked over to her.

"Are you well, Miss Daisy?" Leris asked with concern in her voice. She looked sideways at the young half-elf, saw that her face showed sadnes.

"I just got lost in the memories. Nothing special." she said with difficulty bringing a smile to her face.

"Is it because Lady Cala's been gone so long? Don't worry, she'll be fine, you've trained her well." said the maid in a comforting tone.

She couldn't help but burst into hysterical laughter. Indeed, *I have trained her well. I gave her knowledge that none of my previous students had received. I've also never had someone so… smart and eager to learn… I should be so proud!* she laughed under her breath again. She was aware that Leris was starting to worry seeing her increasingly sullen and bitter mood, but she couldn't help it. She had hurt countless beings in her life, and she was expected to be willing to hurt more. She didn't feel like putting on a mask of joy...

She left her black coat to the servant in the hall. Tey bowed humbly to her, and she felt a surge of good cheer. At least for a while, she will allow himself to forget about hers past and future. She will enjoy the moment, the life she has always wanted. For as long as she could remember, she had dreamed of being respected and admired, even if it meant being feared. Now she had finally got what she wanted… though she knew well the price she would have to pay. P*ower has a price that most mortals on Etheria have never imagined. Were you Prime aware of the darkness that exists between the stars? Oh what a fool you were. If you really saw everything and knew everything, your mind would shatter into a thousand screaming pieces*. She smiled with grim satisfaction before saying goodbye to Leris and entering the great ballroom.

She felt a satisfaction mixed with joy as she saw the voices stop and everyone turn to her. She was Miss Daisy, a mysterious and powerful sorceress with knowledge and power reminiscent of the Lost Golarion. None of them realized how much time she had spent learning modern magic theory... Or how little the modern mystics understood the power the First Ones had at their disposal. She greeted more people, so awkwarded in her presence. Most knew of her scars, but discretion was considered a great virtue in Carurystal, especially among the nobility. Everyone believed there had been an accident during the ritual…which was true. The few people who guessed the truth either stayed silent or served the same damed power which was behind her… But there were people who worried even her, a woman whose name was a curse spoken with fear or hatred. Archduke Adamson, a tall red-haired man whose cold blue eyes brought back too many memories for her to feel safe under their watchful gaze. The ruler of the planet was a mysterious person, a skillful politician who efficiently managed his domain. She guessed he maintained a spy network, though Carurystal officially had no intelligence agency. Alone in the Fright Zone she used Hordak's money to pay agents and informers, although she always had to be skillful in disguising such expenses. Her former superior treated such forms of warfare with contempt, although as it turned out later, he could appreciate them, which almost turned out to be her undoing. So she avoided spies and informers who might be hiding among the servants of Grayskull Castle and their neighbors, even though most of Lady Cala' and her allies activities were concentrated off-planet. Better beware, especially since there were a few people on Carurystal who harbored some suspicions about her lady and the circumstances in which her relatives had passed away.

"Hello Miss Daisy. You are the jewel that embellishes every important event that takes place in our great kingdom." said a tall mechanical creature with a grey-green body. At first glance, it looked like a robot, one of those advanced and self-aware robots, but upon closer inspection it was clear that it had no electronic

parts, and veins of red liquid were visible beneath the metal plates.

"Prince Zed, that's a nice compliment, but someone like me could be black garnet or something like that." she said, smiling gently at the creature. A servant with a tray full of glasses of white wine approached them, and they each took one, though the automaton merely held it as if to make it appear more *alive*.

"You are too modest, you are probably the most powerful sorceress on the planet, and this is just one of the many talents you possess. You shouldn't hide in the shadows like some outcast or black sheep."

She frowned. She wondered for a moment what the prince might know. He was not only one of the richest inhabitants of the planet, but also an ancient construct created by the Jistka Empire on the Lost Golarion, which he made no secret of. She knew the stories of these ancient beings, but she never thought she would meet them…" I witnessed the myth come back to life. Now I'm talking to a myth while having a drink... The world has gone mad, or maybe it's just me who's mad." On Etheria, the idea of self-aware machines was merely a matter of speculation, even after the arrival of the Horde, true artificial intelligence was virtually unknown. Until finally the sword was found, and the purple-haired girl got to one of the Horde bots. But the prince was something else, a machine based on magic. A creature that would arouse the admiration and envy of even the First Ones.

The problem was that the prince was a friend of the Grayskull family and felt sorry for her parents, or so he claimed. He was certainly on friendly terms with Lady Caly's father, Griefrag Grayskull, she even had access to their correspondence, and he had visited the estate several times and met little Lady. From what the ward told her, he tried to make friends with her, but at the time she did not understand the meaning of such relationships. Though he was kind to them, she knew he wanted to know the truth about the fate of House Grayskull. It was a blessing in

misfortune that he blamed her for the tragedies that befell the Grayskull family, not the real perpetrator.

"It's not right for someone like me to outshine his employer. I am a gardener and I know that beautiful flowers will never bloom in the shadow." she replied with a modest smile. Together they walked across the hall.

"By the way, how is our wonderful Lady. He's still on the Pact Worlds?" The prince asked with a hint of sadness in his voice.

"She has gone on a very important visit, the purpose of which remains a secret that I am not allowed to reveal."she said formally. Soon, at least partially, the truth will come to light and everyone will admire the courage of the young Lady ready to set off on a journey into the unknown. What would happen next, not even her dark patrons knew.

"We miss her. It's been over three months since she left Carurystal. Many worry that some harm may have happened to her. - Said the ancient mechanism slowly. She glanced sideways at him, not hiding an indulgent smile. *He really think I wanted to eliminate Lady Cala? If I really wanted to do that, I wouldn't be doing the whole show with a journey.*

"You don't have to worry about Lady Cala. She grew up to be a strong and confident woman who can handle almost any danger." *Also with a machine pretending to be a living being, she thought maliciously.* They walked over to a table piled full of dishes. Carurystal's cuisine wasn't fancy, but it was hearty and much heavier than what the people of Mystacor were used to, though in truth she couldn't remember much of what it tasted like. Beside her stood Rakhe, Veskarium's ambassador. Warlike lizardmen had always evoked in her indescribable feelings. Many Vesks served in the Horde. On Etheri, however, they did not use their true name. Their name was Vaste, which many attributed, she had y discovered, erroneously, to their origins in the Crimson Waste. Even one of them was under the department she oversaw, and he was friends with Adora and perhaps a little with Catra, but if she

remembered correctly, he had a much c*loser relationship* with Lonnie and Kyle. I wonder what the Vesk ambassador would say to that.

"Another year of service on our beautiful Carurystal has passed. What are the ambassador's plans for strengthening relations between our wonderful planet and Veskarium" she asked her, smiling maliciously. Wet and cloudy, and above all reluctant to military solutions, Carurystal was a place of exile for the Vesks. During her rule, border with Kingdom of Snow was something similar

"Well, given your troubles with the Kranor Rill and the increasingly frequent Riliti attacks, perhaps I'll talk to the Archduke about possible military cooperation between our countries." said Rakhe, baring her fangs.

She narrowed her eyes. She don’t like Vesks. Fanatical devotion to the dark honor reminded her too much of those from the past to whom she had sacrificed so much. *Just who do I really feel sorry for?*

"The Riliti are savage beasts who can only use technology by imitating more evolved races. Only a sense of sapienism prevents us from completely exterminating them." said Prince Zed with amusement, but she answered him with absolute seriousness pouring herself a glass of whiskey

"It is very imprudent to underestimate an opponent just because he seems to us primitive and technically undeveloped. It can hide secrets that we have never dreamed of. From my own experience, I know perfectly well that it is extremely easy to put a would-be winner in shackles." she said angry tone. She knew she had revealed quite a lot about her past, but she didn't care. It didn't matter much now anyway. He'll be leaving this place soon anyway, and he'll never come back. There is no future for her.

"You have a lot to say about waging war as for an elven…witch." Veska said, looking at her with superiority.

"Much more than any Veska ambassador. On politics and economics, probably also " *Idiot, I just supported you.*

Theoretically, the ambassador could challenge her to a glorious combat now, though she would probably lose her post. But Rakhe knew she wouldn't stand a chance of surviving this encounter. She stared at it for a long moment, until the Ambassador looked down. She smiled grimly with dark satisfaction, feeling a pleasant shiver. She'd always been good at that, at making others tremble with fear. Fear made them easier to control.

I'm still the old me. I'm still… She felt a wave of self-loathing wash over her and reached for her glass of red wine, which she emptied in one gulp.

"Slow down, Miss Daisy, we have the whole night ahead of us." Prince Zed laughed. His voice was surprisingly melodious and pleasant sounding.

"I thought a little ... Returning to Riliti, you have to transfer the war to their territory. Constantly harass their settlements with constant attacks. Break their fighting spirit, because when they lose it, they will easily succumb to us."

"You really do have a lot of experience in warfare, especially for an ordinary ... What is your profession exactly?" asked the automaton, delight in his voice. *Do you want to examine me? Exmine me, if you want, you won't learn anything new.*

Several people gathered around her, listening to their conversation. The Riliti have always aroused great emotions among the otherwise peaceful inhabitants of Carurystal. Rakhe decided to take oportunity and left with a sour expression on her face.

"I had to learn very fast to survive. The prince cannot imagine what things living beings can do to survive." she said in a grim voice. Food has lost its appeal to her. *You're getting sad drunk, my*

dear Shadow Weaver, that's a lot of progress, You don't zap kids she laughed inside.

"The truth about war can only be learned by facing the enemy and learning from our own and others' failures." said a voice she had never heard before. She looked up to see a tall woman dressed in the black and red Hellknights dress representative uniform with the symbol of the sun in an eclipse. She had red-gold hair and a scar on her cheek, probably from acid. She was about forty human years old, though there were ways in the galaxy to stay young. She was quite attractive, like a bronze statue forged in the heat of battle. *What am I thinking about. I must have had too much to drink* she thought with a strange embarrassment.

- Is it some sort of quote from the sacred books of the Order, or your tactics manuals? -Prince Zed asked with a surprisingly polite smile on his face.
The woman winced.

"No, that's the saying of Lord Admiral Antares." she said with a barely perceptible, probably unintentional, contempt in her voice. "Antares is a real source of sayings that sound very wise." said the woman from the order of the eclipse.

Hearing the Lord Admiral's name, she raised an eyebrow. She had already gathered information about him, and most of it focused on his accomplishments in the Swarm War. More accurate information, especially from thirty years ago, before he was banished from Tarak, was unfortunately hard to come by. "Thirty years, what an important date for both of us. At the same time, we lost our home… although in my case it was a consequence of my ambition." Unfortunately, she had no direct access to the espionage network of Creeping Chaos and their allies everywhere in the galaxy. Now she had found a source of information, and that source was interesting in itself. She searched her mind over the list of people who might have attended the ball, but there was no hellknights on it… but she remembered the latest rumors.

"Ah, Lady of Blades, Asindesa di Vir... I didn't know you'd want to come to the Archduke's birthday party." she said, not hiding the surprise in her voice. Asindesa winced.

"I didn't do it for fun, but out of duty to represent the Order of the Eclipse. If it were up to me, I would oversee the repair of my ship. Unfortunately, I still have to wait for all the parts to arrive. - the knight said firmly. Prince Zed nodded in understanding.

"You were attacked by a space monster. You were very lucky that all ended only with damaged ship. My memories of the old Golarion are very fragmentary, but I remember how great fear aroused in sailors the prospect of an attack by sea beasts that could drag them into the abyss of the seas, and yet the abyss of space is much more terrifying.

The Lady of Blades glanced at the automaton, then gave her a questioning look. She shrugged and said.

"Prince Zed is from Lost Golarion. He is an Automaton if I understand correctly, a being created by magic, not technology." She explained to the knight, and the prince bowed politely.

"Indeed, you are absolutely right, but now I would ask the ladies to let me go. Much less pleasant matters are calling me, involving the investment in the construction of an orbital station. Carurystal deserves it!" he uttered the last point in such a tone as if it were an election slogan. They both snorted. They were left alone, for the guests who had gathered around them had discreetly dispersed.

"Hellknights are as popular here as anywhere." Asindesa murmured with a hint of satisfaction mixed with bitterness.

"It's rather my fault. I have my ways of letting people know that I don't want company. I enjoy a certain… authority here. Would you like to walk?"she asked the Lady of Blades, who nodded her agreement. They walked together through the huge banquet hall.

"How do you know the Lord Admiral?" she asked hellknight

"'We fought together against The Swarm. Why do you ask, Miss Daisy." she asked, looking at her sharply.

"So you know who I am." *Or rather, you think you know* "I am worried and would like to know who I am dealing with." *Rather not for Lady Caly's safety, though. Actually, I'm more worried about this man* she thought with grim amusement. Asindesa thought for a moment.

"He is an outstanding commander, especially when it comes to space combat, but he also knows how to conduct battles on the surface of planets. But above all, he is a brilliant politician. He can turn every battle, even a defeat, into a great triumph. They say war is just an extension of politics, for him that's truth. He wins every fight first in salons and in the media. As he used to say, the greatest victory is the one you get without firing a single shot." Asindesa said sharply.

Oh Hordak, this is something even your brother couldn't comprehend... Though should'nt I have told you off, since I was your's right hand responsible for most of what you did.

"What do you think of him as a person? " she asked the knight again, reaching for another glass of red wine, ignoring the fact that Asindesa gave her a surprised look. *Why do I feel ashamed?*

"He's… very reserved. He never reveals what he feels or thinks. He is always prepared for what the future may bring... He is absolutely focused on the goal and nothing can distract him... has something happened?" Asindesa asked suddenly as she saw her shiver. There was concern in her voice.

"It just reminded me of a certain horrible woman I knew." she said far too fast to sound believable. Asindesa nodded and asked herself.

"Was it worth it? What have you done…" Asindesa asked her . She replied with a bitter smile. *Hellknights know a lot about dark pacts, after all.*

- No... And not just because of the scars...- She said sharply and finished her wine, then looked down. *You did what you did. You brought suffering and you knew very well that you were hurting others.*

She felt a heavy hand on her shoulder. Asindesa smiled at her. She felt a strange, almost unknown so far warmth spreading through her body. *It's stupid. It's so stupid. Focus idiot! After all, that's what you've always demanded fro others* she reprimanded herself.

Then the music started and she felt Asindesa grab her hands. Like most planets in the galaxy, Carurystal had no prejudice against same-sex relationships, but of course appropriately polite and unobtrusive ways of signaling one's orientation had to be devised. One of them was inviting someone to dance. She looked at Asidesa di Vir in genuine surprise

"Can wizards dance where you come from?"asked the knight of hell with a cunny smile

"No worse than the Helknights." she replied and laughed happily. She felt young for a moment, not least because of what Nyarlathotep had done to her body. She learned dancing in her family home, where she studied for The Spider chosen one. She had to be good at it because she had no choice. She taught them… Adora and Catra how to dance and it was one of the few good things she had done in her life.

She has slept with both men and women in her life. But she had never felt what she felt now. *It's the alcohol in my veins, nothing more* she repeated over and over again, but deep down she knew otherwise. There was the first dance, and the second, and the tenth. Finally, they stood looking into each other's eyes and feeling their hearts beating in unison

.
"I never thought I'd ever dance with a hellknight." she exclaimed, laughing happily.

"Most people think we only live to wage our war. Maybe there is a bit of truth in it, but ... I did not think that I would find someone on this planet with such a hunger for life inside." cried the Lady of Blades.

Yes... Hunger she thought. Creeping Chaos completed the ritual she had begun so long ago. It wasn't until she was resurrected that she realized that Mikah's sacrifice was necessary for the ritual to be complete. Creeping chaos liked to play with fools who believed that power would make them happy.

"I... I've really never met anyone like you. For now, Lady Cala is in the process of fulfilling her mission. So I have some free time, so I'd like to invite you to Castle Grayskull to spend some time together." she said, feeling like a teenager inviting her friend to spend the night together.

But then Asindesa looked down and pursed her lips.

"I am so orry, but I have to decline. I'm getting ready for an extremely important mission and I don't have time for such nonsense."
"But why? Have I offended you in some way?" she asked strangely sad. She knew the taste of disappointment well, but this was more than that. She felt as if she had lost something very precious, something much more precious than the power she had been chasing all her life.

The hellknight shook her head.

"We both have our responsibilities. Each of us serves someone and in no way can we abandon this service. I guess this could be the beginning of... something beautiful, but none of us can afford it."

"Well, the war with the Swarm ..." she said gloomily, but after a moment of thought the Lady of Blades denied

"No ... the Order chose me to participate in an extremely important and dangerous mission. It is related to Lord Admiral

Antares... that's why I quoted him, because I've been thinking a lot about him lately... I can't say anything more... " painful sadness could be heard in the knight's voice.

She put two and two together and understood. *So you're going where we are. If you knew the truth… the truth, you'd understand that someone like you has nothing to fear out there… except for people like me… And like Calamity.* She thought sadly, but she was already planning how to continue this relationship, even though deep down she knew it would end in their shared suffering.

Crossfire

" Traveling is about getting to know not only the beautiful places that are shown on postcards, but also the less pleasant ones." Rosie said in sign language. "And I guess Saltmarsh is definitely one of those places."

"Saltmarsh isn't even fit for the backwaters of the universe. It's not even nasty. It just exists and collects dust." Dilayla said with contempt clearly audible in her voice.

"Well, at least it's original." Rosie said with a friendly smile.

Dilayla shook her head in disbelief.

"Are you always like this? Do you always try to see the better side of everything and everyone?"

The deaf girl spread her hands.

"Why not? If you do that, then others will try to treat you as you treat them, it's quite simple." She said and smiled widely. Dilayla looked at her, unsure of what to say.

"The world doesn't work that way. I mean, some people will probably react the way you say, but many have no conscience. They'll only hurt you because they'll have the opportunity. Not even because they gain something from it, but because your suffering will make them happy. And you are much easier to hurt than others."

Rosie made a indignant face.

" I can take care of myself! I can fight. I'm really good at this."

Dilayla looked at her companion. The intern was clad in good, if fairly standard, armor, a gift from one of her tutors at the university. She also had a backpack, datapad, and other standard equipment necessary for traveling to remote and wild regions of

the galaxy. But she was a petite girl, even without the power armor she was a head taller than she was, and she had no weapons.

"If you say so." murmured the mercenary. They were in one of the worst districts of Saltmarsh, though she supposed the difference between the worst and best districts in a place like this was purely arbitrary. Everywhere, most of the inhabitants were armed, and law enforcement was practically non-existent ... But on the other hand, it was difficult to talk about real crime, because most of the inhabitants here were armed, and law enforcement was practically non-existent. Everyone did their own justice here, there wasn't even a customary law to tidy things up a bit. *In a land of lawlessness, everyone is righteous.* she recalled an old saying from her hometown. Throughout this trip, she thought more and more about Minitar, she wasn't sure if it was because of the Order's participation in this project, or maybe because of the strange premonitions that the had tormented her hardened heart of mercenary. W*e lived so close to this place. Will I find there the truth that has been denied me?*

In fact, she didn't like places like Saltmarsh. She may have been a mercenary, but unlike many of her profession, she had a moral code or something. In the company of Rechza and Arkan, she could play the Dog of War who cares about nothing, but she was a devoted follower of the Inheritor and tried to choose such assignments that allowed her to keep a reasonably clear conscience. Besides, she really didn't want to be in a place where she could end up with a knife in her back because someone was having a bad day.

Passers-by kept out of her way, probably because she was in possession of one of the few power armors on the planet. She didn't wear a helmet, so she could scowl at anyone who got too close. Rosie, on the other hand, was looking at everything and everyone with awe, as if she were on a trip. More and more often Dilayla wondered if the one who had sent her on such a dangerous journey wasn't an idiot detached from reality, or just wanted to get rid of her, although it was hard to imagine why

anyone would want to get rid of such a carefree creature. *Unless someone is going to get their hands on a secret inheritance or a hidden trust fund that the girl didn't know about.* It even made some sense, after all, the girl had these mysterious patrons, who knows who they really were.

There was one more thing about the girl.

:Rosie, why don't you fix your hearing with implants? Or a tissue transplant?" she asked her companion. Rosie looked at her and shrugged.

"In my case, it wouldn't work anyway." she unwound her snow-white hair and pointed to her ear. The pinna was attached to the body and the ear canal was overgrown with tissue.

"I don't have anything inside my ear. Even my brain is deprived of this piece to hearing. I guess my whole family and my ancestors didn't hear either." said the girl "And besides, it's good. I'm hapy I can do a everything. I guess I was trained in the old days to do…a lot of things. I'm not sure who did it or why, but it doesn't really matter anymore." she shrugged. Dilayla sighed.

"It matters a lot because it will determine how much care I have to make sure no one kills you. she said slowly. Rosie gave her a hurt look.

"If my clumsiness annoys you so much, why did you bring me with you?!" The vouce from gloves screamed.

"Because I don’t want to leave you with that mean ratiess." The mercenary muttered in a gloomy voice.

"I don't need your pity or anyone else's." Rosie huffed and crossed her arms over her chest.

There was silence, but it didn't last long as they were. approaching the Red Water bar. It was a real haven for mercenaries and adventurers who wanted to rest between their quests. Dilayla had been to such places often, though she was not

particularly fond of them. She liked a decent pub or an upper-class brothel where she could relax, but at least it wasn't a murder house where everyone was waiting to slit your throat. A place like Saltmarsh did not produce warriors neither the toughest nor the cunning, but those who became masters of survival. Such a poor and completely forgotten planet could give little to those who made a living from solving all sorts of problems, because the inhabitants learned to solve them themselves. Bu*t it's also a place where it's easy to hide and find peace.* Dilayla thought, looking at the bartender and probably the owner of this enterprise, the mighty Pahtra, with a scarred face. He looked quite menacing, though not to veterans like her. A burn mark on her arm caught her attention. She swore silently under her breath.

"Rosie, don't tell anyone about the hundred-damned Lord Admiral." she said quietly.

"About who?" asked the confused girl, in the opinion of the mercenary definitely too loud.

"Just don't say anything about our journey. Better yet, pretend you are… Just turn off those glasses and gloves. whispered the half-elf. Rosie made a strange sound that was supposed to be a growl, but realized she didn't really know what kind of noise a girl could make. It was… a strange thought.

As soon as they entered, most of the regulars of this establishment looked at her. She looked really professional, and she took pride in the fact that she looked neater than the scumbags present. Most had weapons, quite good ones in a few cases, but no armor. However, they were professionals who rather wanted to relax in each other's company, so the heavily armed mercenary in power armor, contrary to appearances, completely did not fit here and disrupted the existing order. She raised her hand in a conciliatory gesture.

"Queue for everyone! she called with a fake smile, but the free drink meant that no one cared about her intentions anymore. She

went to the bar to pay with the Lord Admiral's money, and several of the regulars snorted at the sight of Rosie.

"Why are they staring at me? And then they poit to you? " she asked the mercenary, carefully looking around. Dilayla smiled sarcastically.

"You are a young girl accompanying an older one who seem to be a successful mercenary.

The intern widened her eyes.

"They think I'm…" She started to blush.
"Sleeping bag friend, though that's the politest word for such persons. Don't worry, you're not my type." said the half-elf.

"Your type?" asked the deaf girl very carefully.

"I'm over forty, have a risky but profitable profession and prefer girls. I've relationship with a lot of women, but none of them lasted long. But I won't hit on you, so don't worry." Dilayla said and ordered a water and juice for Rosie and a beer for herself, then walked over to it.

"Hello sir..."She raised an eyebrow questioningly.

"Zagsos." the bartender replied grimly, staring at her with his golden eyes.

"Well, Mr. Zagsos, I'm going straight to the point. Does anyone here have a ship for sale?" she asked smiling slightly.

"What do you need a ship for?: the Catman asked, wiping glass.

"I won't make a secret of it. Armed people like me appear on this planet cursed by Devils and Daemons for only one purpose, and the fact that I am looking for a ship is an additional hint" she yawned a bit bored with such a pointless exchange of sentences.

"Some say that no one comes back from there." Zagsos said after a moment's thought.

That's interesting thought Dilayla. *I'm getting valuable information.*

"So some people are coming back?"she asked, clearly interested.

"Look at that one over there." he pointed to Shiren sitting at the table, staring glumly into the distance. "It's Shirkas. He is a miner extracting valuable resources from asteroids. A few months ago he fell into huge debts and went deep into the Ravaged Zone. When he arrived from there, he brought with him a lot of money and *Scary* stories.

"Ah, that's interesting... But why does he want to sell the ship then?" Dilayla said suspiciously.

"Because the money he brought was like that…"He showed her the coin. It was red with a symbol of golden wings on the obverse and the words *United we will cast out shadows*. She had never seen such a coin. The symbol of wings reminded her of something. Hard money was relatively unused in the galaxy, but as a mercenary she had to use it in the frontiner regions where there was a greater demand for people dabbling in her profession. She also learned to recognize the value of coins, and she didn't like it very much.

"They're not worth much." she said with disgust.
"Yes, and they say he exchanged the entire contents of the hold on a one-for-one basis." Zagsos said contemptuously. "And when he came back, he acted like he had made the deal of a lifetime. Well, for a miner, he didn't show off his knowledge of metallurgy. He came back with more debts than he originally had."

She shrugged.

"I know ways to cheat someone on the value of coins. And I'm just an ordinary hired gun." she said, and paid Pahtra fifty credits. Then she walked over to Shiren. He was quite large for a

representative of this species, but had rather elongated limbs and not very thick joints, which indicated physical weakness. A fairly common ailment among beings who spend a lot of time in open space.

Shirkas spread his antennae with concern when he saw her.

"What do you want from me?" he asked very carefully. As she smiled, the miner cringed. His antennae were now clinging to his head. She noticed that one of them had a scratched chitin. Apparently he got into a fight, although he was not predisposed to it.

"We want to buy your ship, we give you... a hundred thousand credits. she said, wondering if she would bargain.

"Hundred thousand! You can take it now!" he cried. She was a bit surprised that it went so quickly.

"My comrades have to agree first, and then we have to see if it's not some kind of junk." she said carefully. *If he wants to sell me a wreck, I'll crush his stupid Shiren head.*

"Of course. Noble Endeavor is a wonderful ship. A bit crude inside, but can handle almost anything." Insectoid said with fiery enthusiasm.

"We'll be there in the afternoon. But first, I'd like to ask you something else... Where did you get these coins from? The ones no one wanted to accept from you. " she asked, placing the combat glove on the table. Shiren lowered his head.

"You see, when we left the zone, we come out the Drift, because earlier I wanted to check whether it would be worth organizing a base on one planet, and then ... A ship arrived, so from outside the drift. White and weird and we were ordered to let someone on board. So I let them in, as they said, and... the Drow arrived, a woman, I think. She looked like a mystic or a priestess, and she questioned me about various things, but first she bought all my

goods. Everything and for double the value, or so I thought. She showed me a coin that looked fine.

„An old trick” thought Dilayla, then asked.

"What about that scary thing you met there?"

Shiren shivered and drank a glass of the sweet stuff his race liked so much.

"Because we flew far, into the middle of the Zone... And that's where I came out of the Drift. We've already collected our cargo... But I was curious what's next, but when we got there... I picked up the signal. He was hard to pick up, but as soon as I caught him, it blew our transmitter. But for two seconds I saw her. It must have been the female of one of you. She had something on her head that looked like your uh... hair, but it was moving." He asked for a new glass, which he immediately emptied.

"It waved at me as if mockingly promising me peace. The woman was smiling, but I know she was screaming in her heart. I know it! - He finished another glass and called out. "That lady will paid."

She smiled at Shiren, though in her heart she wanted to punch him in his mouth.

"Funny... Listen to me, bug. If your ship turns out to be suitable for us, we'll buy it, but if you try to cheat me, I'll gouge out your brains with your own antennae.

Shirkas looked at her for a moment.

"Do you know that I was threatened in this way today?" Shiren said, not too scared.

"Only I'm not joking." She said without stopping smiling.

"She didn't look like she was joking either." Shirkas said quietly.

She asked for directions to where they would meet and then got up and walked over to Rosie, who was drawing something on the table.

"Alright young one, let's go?" said the mercenary, ordering the intern to get up, glanced at the table and saw that the girl was drawing some ridiculous stars.
When they left, Rosie asked her." Did you manage to arrange everything?

"Even more than I wanted." said Dilayla, tapping her pocket where she had put the coin she had taken from Zagsos.

"What was your point of me not talking about anything?.."The intern looked at the half-elf questioningly.

Dilayla turned around and made sure they were far enough away from the bar that no one could hear them, especially a certain Pahtra.

"He belongs, or rather belonged to the Shadows of Tarak." Many years ago, a civil war broke out on Tarak. On one side was the "Loyalist Alliance" linked to the Pact Worlds, to which belonged, or rather, it was led by the Lord Admiral. Second side was, the Glorious Rebellion supported by Veskarium." Dilayla said in a hushed voice.

"But the Vesks are… They like dictatorships and stuff. So why did they support the rebellion?" Rosie asked, a bit confused.

"Vesks are diverse, just like any race. And that was the issue of the rivalry between Veskarium and the Pact Worlds. Those were the times of the Cold War. In any case, the Shadows of Tarak were an elite special task force. For some they were heroes, for others terrorists. I'm not one who can say who was right…" she spoke thoughtfully, but Rosie cut her off.

"But usually it's probably that one side is, you know... the good one... the one that defends itself."The deaf girl was clearly confused. Dilayla laughed.

"Sometimes it does. But not in the case of a civil war, especially when it was a proxy war. The Rebellion won, but terrible things have happened, and the Shadows were banished from the planet along with their leader Igzar, an extremely nasty Pahtra who had sworn to hunt down the Lord Admiral... They became mercenaries and worked for various clients for many years, but never abandoned their mission. Igzar supposedly died a few years ago, but the Shadows still stick together, so I don't think it would be a good idea that they know who we work for. she told the deaf girl. Rosie thought for a moment.

"So where exactly are we going now?" she asked finally, clearly subdued.

"We've got some time, so I'm going to the junkyard. Firstly, I'll be able to buy some equipment there, although I doubt there's anything of real value there, and secondly, we need to exchange credits for hard currency." said the mercenary. She was also going to buy any kind of weapon for her companion to at least look like one that could defend herself

"But why?" Rosie asked in surprise.

"Because Abbadar Corp's influence doesn't extend there, even if they have any electronic equipment there.' And we know that at least one group uses coins. - Dilayla said, smiling friendly to make the deaf girl feel a little better. This conversation must have sadened her. Rosie seemed very sensitive. Sooner or later she would have to lose her innocence and faith in others, but it didn't have to be because of Dilayla.

The area was a bit desolate, full of half-finished buildings and half-empty warehouses where those damn flies were probably stored. Dilayla didn't like places like that either. They were too stimulating her natural mercenary instinct, which she had developed over the years of fighting in wars not her own. *There is no better place in the whole city to set up an ambush. No one will come to help, if hears the sounds of fighting, no one will be interested* She snorted at her own thoughts to push them away,

but she still felt an irritating tingle of uneasiness down the back of her neck. Rosie touched her shoulder and was about to turn around, but then she saw someone in the road. Three young people, a dragonkin and two girls, and a strange three-legged droid with a spherical, motley body. Two were armed, and the third had Solarian markings on his arms. But they wouldn't draw a mercenary's attention, they didn't look like they were about to attack someone. But one of them was with them. The White Demon… It's rather motley at the moment… He was dressed in a strange shirt, probably made by Skitermander's, and dyed his hair in rainbow colors, but he was still one of them. *Where did he come from? Are they planning a new invasion? And does it matter?* she thought, and then Rosie shouted at her.

"Dilayla, they're following us!"

"I see!" she said, and the laser canon moved from her back to her shoulder. She fired, but the White Demon dodged, and the solarian summoned the moonblade as well.

"Thanks Rosie!" she said, and then felt a powerful slap to the back. She looked over her shoulder and saw the great Vesk with a heavy hammer. She snarled and swung the combat gauntlet, but then Rosie hit Vesk in the ribs and shoulder. She heard the crunch of breaking bones. The girl's hands glowed.

Eti decided that this whole mision to rescue Wormdak was completely, and absolutely pointless. Only did they free clone this dumb robot with this strange scar. Why were they involved? They just lost lots of charges. She even had to recharge her's better hand. *Does itel understand how much batteries cost? And then Bina resents them, quite rightly so!* She thought as she jumped from roof to roof. The only good thing about all this completely senseless fuss was that the threat of stormy days was gone. Now she wasn't so full of delight of herself. She felt… not much, except perhaps annoyance. She stood on the edge of the roof and unrolled her hood, taking off her goggles and mask. Someone was walking down the street. Two people. The first was a person in

power armor, large and relentlessly noisy, and the second was much smaller and moved with grace. She looked that way and saw a blue-haired half-elf in power armor and a white-haired girl. But she heard something else. In the distance, several other people were approaching the two. Three of them belonged to some large creatures that were very clumsy in stealth, making more noise than a woman in power armor. But there was someone else, a true professional. She only heard him because he slipped on a brick without mortar. She looked in that direction and saw a piece of green armor. The figure, however, immediately hid behind a half-collapsed wall. She couldn't get a better look at it without giving away her location. She wondered for a moment what was going on here, but decided to let Itel know, she always has some brilliant plan.

"Itel, to that armored chick..." She didn't finish as the armored chick just opened fire on... *Wormdak? Who would want to shoot Wormdak? He's just a clone. It's a waste of charges* she thought, and saw that the figures hiding earlier turned out to be three Vesks dressed in local nomad costumes. One of them hit the woman in the back with a heavy rail hammer, but the white-haired girl hit Vesk, breaking his arm and ribs. Her hands began to glow. The helmet covered the half-elf's head, but Eti was aiming at her shoulder rifle anyway. She wasn't sure who they were fighting whom, so she decided to neutralize the one that attacked Wormdak first, the real threat was the one hiding. She fired and hit the rifle, perfect as always. She got up and wanted to change the shooting position, but the white-haired girl saw her and ran towards her and jumped on the roof. She stared at her with her mouth open, then whistled in surprise. *This might be interesting.*

Rosie was never quite sure of her training. She could do things, but she had no idea how. She simply knew them ... Sometimes she unexpectedly discovered abilities that she would never suspect herself of having. It was the same now. She knew she could fight, and she knew how to fight amazingly well, eventually getting into a few fights back on Absalom when several people tried to accost a deaf girl. She sent her opponents to the hospital once, which freaked her out a bit. But deep down, she was glad to

be able to defend herself. So when she saw someone shooting at Dilayla, she ran to where the shot came from, and she just knew she could jump in there, even though it was a good four meters above the road. Once on the roof, she faced the shooter and stared in surprise. She thought she was going to run into some thug or something. She saw… she wasn't sure herself. The cat's ears and tail were typical of a Pahtras, but the face was human. Golden eyes with many blue flecks stared at her with a mixture of surprise and astonishment. Then the glasses showed that she had whistled to her. Various people whistled for her when they thought she couldn't hear them, though probably in a different context. Probably… She lunged at the shooter and hit her with her fist, but she dodged and swung her left hand, with the knife attached to it. She jumped back, but then the assailant slapped her face with a strange metal hand, completely different from Dilayla's prosthetics. She felt a sharp pain in her face and spit up, but she punched her opponent in the stomach with all her strength, but she stepped on her foot, and Rosie *screamed* in pain, though the strange whistling sound was hardly a scream, or so the others told her. So she hit the strange Pachtra with her fist in the face, until the other one spat blood from the nose. They jumped away from each other and stared at each other for three heartbeats, but then shooter motioned for her to drop to the ground. She took a risk and did as instructed. Above their heads someone fired a magnetic rifle burst. They got up at the same time and saw the Aeon guardsman. which was hidden behind the corner. Pahtrowata grabbed her pistol and fired twice, and Rosie ran towards him, but the guardsman ran away, and she didn't want to chase him with a potential opponent behind her. She spun around, fists poised for a fight, but the shooter raised her gun.

"alm down, Sparkle Fingers. Things seem to have calmed down down there, so I guess there's no point in us fighting too."

Still with her fists clenched, she glanced at the road below and saw that Dilayla and Pahtra-like friends had stopped fighting, so she jumped down onto the road. Her former opponent ran down the wall.

"Do you guys know who you're walking with? Who is he?" Dilayla asked sharply.

"It's Wormdak, Wormdak only. It was a shame to waste ammo on someone like that." said the shooter. She was now donning her goggle hood and Akiton’s dust mask. A strange white alien with colored hair spoke up

"I am Wrongdak, actually Wrong Hordak. And I know what this woman means. I was one of the White Demons, albeit briefly. My brothers have raided and ravaged planets. They have destroyed countless civilizations in the name of Horde Prime… But he is no more." he smiled sadly. - He was annihilated and is no more. - Relief flashed across Wrongdak's face. - I am sorry for what has been done to your people!

Rosie noticed from the corner of her eye that the green-haired elf, the red-haired human girl and the Dragonkin exchanged knowing glances. Her would-be opponent snorted softly. A strange spherical android painted in dappled colors covered the white-skinned alien.

"Well, a soldier is there to kill, even if he ordered it himself."Dilayla said with a crooked smile. Wrongdak cowered sadly, and Rosie felt sorry for him.

"Listen kids, what are you going to do? I'm guessing you didn't take him in because he was wandering around the street. A weird bunch like you guys are looking for something... on Saltmarsh. Let's say we'll help you find it as compensation." Dilayla said.

The elf hesitated for a moment, but Dragonkin spoke up.

"I'm Alatar, and these are Itel, Lilka and Eti. We are looking for a certain observatory..." he said pointing to his companions. Three Vesk opponents lay on the ground, two were wounded, but one appeared to be dead. Rosie tried not to look in his direction. Vesk, whom she had beaten, coughed.

"If you help me dress my wounds, I'll tell you where it is. An hour away from the city, on a small hill." he said. Dilayla raised an eyebrow. Eti hugged Itel tightly. Rosie felt a pang of sadness for a moment.

Personal goals

Arkan-tar smiled to himself. He felt no remorse for not being completely honest with both his comrades and the Lord Admiral. He guessed that everyone involved had their own personal goals. Lady Cala and her *keeper* weren't just a noblewoman and her servant, and Antares wasn't just a mercenary. He wasn't sure about his other companions. Rehiza had some connection to his friend, but as far as he knew, she served the Order of the Eclipse and could be a minor obstacle. Dilayla, Rosie and Dr. Qin were not hiding any secrets, they were just random participants in an extremely interesting game. Of course, he wasn't fully aware of everything himself, but that only made it all the more interesting.

He went to the cantina at the spaceport. It was a rather pleasant placet, brightly lit and clean, even somewhat sterile. There were two bodyguards here, both androids, and they seemed a bit like siblings, though it was hard to tell with these biomechanical organisms. It served mostly strong Vesks beer and that ubiquitous sweet liquor on this planet that was hard to drink without nausea. The food here, judging by the smell, served mostly reheated packets, though at least they were top-shelf ones. It was mostly members of those few ship crews that stopped here to replenish supplies or buy any valuable goods available here.From the speakers came the unobtrusive music typical of such places, no Shirpop or Orkopunk. It was even pleasant here, although he rather liked more ... dynamic places. But he wasn't here to have fun, there was something for him here. And he was seeking information at the same time, because it was in the interest of all of them. He sat down at a table, ordered a beer from a Shiren waitress. There weren't many guests here at the moment, so he decided to join the interesting half-drow and the huge Veska with a huge hammer on his back. At a glance, he could tell free pirates apart from corsairs and fanatical cultists.

"Hello, I'm Arkan-tar." He offered them his hand and the half-drow shook it.

"I'm Boatswain Kaert." he said, and Veska growled.

"And I am Gydwa." She gave Verthani a stern look.

"Second mate on Merciless." Kaert finished her’s sentence halfway. He seemed to be very drunk already, but also quite likable for Arkan's taste.

"Merciless, is that a ship..." he searched his Exocotex resources. "of Captain Moonshadow. i presume correctly?"He looked at them with admiration. *Such a pirate in such a place... It could be a coincidence, but...*

"Yeah, that's her... We're taking part in a wonderful expedition, and then we're back to fight with the Azlanti. said the half-drow, but Veska glared at him. *Oh mysteries, interesting* thought the scholar.

"I am a member of an archaeological expedition organized by Kemanis University and funded by Lady Cala Grayskull of Carurystal. - he said after taking a few sips of beer. He looked over the foam at the interlocutors.

"How much they're paying you? You know, we could use a decent scholar to show us which shells are worth something and which can be used as shooting targets instead of tin cans."

"And so the spell was broken. I'm talking with the ignorant." "Well, if you have the right contacts, there is no such thing as worthless shells. Every remnant of lost civilizations gives us clues about how they functioned, so it is valuable, and often priceless." Arkan-tar said with a hint of superiority in his voice. Sam didn't have clean hands. He destroyed many relics of the past as he sought to obtain the more valuable treasures. Well, the work of an archaeologist and explorer involved fierce competition and often required difficult decisions to be made.

"I told you our captain knows what she's doing, and you constantly suspect her of the worst. You could show her the

respect due to someone who will make you rich." said Kaert too loudly as someone who is already heavily drunk.

Veska gurgled menacingly.

"If I'm going to get rich picking up garbage, I'd rather scrub the deck for the rest of my life." she said grimly, looking at Boatswain.

"Oh, I see that Veska's honor has awakened in someone." The half-drow laughed violently, spitting beer at Verthani. „Definitely not worth my time, Arkan-tar thought as Veska eyed the boatswain with a clear desire to kill.

"It's very interesting. But I have a question, where are you going?" the archaeologist asked, trying to extract information about the destination of his interlocutors. *Coincidences happen and a true explorer must be able to take advantage of them, but he must not confuse them with the deliberate action of third parties.*

"Not yours..." Gydwa wanted to say,

"Into the zone... to a place called... Enteria, Emeria... Etheria!" he said loudly.

"First I hear, and I know a lot about lost civilizations. Could you tell more? " he asked, trying to control his emotions. *And now it's starting to get unsettling.*

"The captain comes from there, apparently it is full of ancient artifacts ... This is confirmed by some data we have obtained ..." said Keart and called for another beer.

"Did you get them from an Azlanti ship?" he asked with an indulgent smile.

"Yes, how do you know?" asked the surprised boatswain.

"Because you're an imbecile. Your captain is known throughout the galaxy for raiding Azlanti ships…" Arkan-tar thought.

" It's quite a well known story ... in certain circles. The Azlanti allow their ships to be captured, and leave information about the hidden treasure there, and the pirates go to the indicated place and die there in trap." he said in a grim voice. His debaters exchanged glances. Veska looked triumphant, and the half-drow was scared. "Well, I have to go to the restroom, see ya!" Verthani called, and got up from the table. As he turned away from the two bewildered pirates, he allowed himself a shy smile.

The bathroom in this establishment was pretty good, though it was a spaceport cantina, so it had to maintain a certain standard. He took care of a minor need, washed his hands and then walked over to the mirror and slipped an implant screwdriver from his finger and unscrewed it. There he found a message left for him. He read it, then ignited it with the micro laser hidden in his other finger. The order he got from his patron contained an important clue ... But unfortunately it required further work from him. He didn't put the mirror back in place, he didn't have time, and he didn't want to go out through the main hall, he noticed how that Giant Veska was watching at him, and he didn't want to get in her way again. He took a micro-folding stool, normally the size of a matchbox, from his pocket and placed it under a small window near the ceiling. Using the screwdriver again, he unhooked the window and laid it gently on the floor. Then he climbed up and squeezed through the hole. He fell through the other side with a groan. His job required a lot of physical fitness. He was not an academic, but a field worker, forcing his way through thickets of carnivorous bushes and examining a hundred-times cursed shipwrecks. Despite it, he had to rub his aching arm for a moment. But he couldn't waste any time. Those two were busy for now, but he was sure Veska would want to find out what was going on with him and why he had broken his neck… He could defend himself, but he wasn't going to risk it. He dusted himself off and headed towards where the Relief was supposed to be. He needed the help of his companions in getting to the place he found out about, and besides, they would support him if a couple of pirates wanted to bother him.

Rechiza didn't expect them to find the ship so quickly. She even expected them to fail. After all, spaceships aren't something you can buy in the fair, and in this goddamn shitjole of the universe, getting one should be impossible. And here the ship basically found them. Under other circumstances, she would have considered this incredible luck, but now...

She wasn't sure if she had done the right thing by agreeing to this mission. She owed a great debt to the Order, and they have common enemies. They shared common goals. However, her personal goal was ... to find answers to the puzzles she came across on Cracked Skull *It's not true ... You are looking for something completely different. Something with a much more pronounced flavor.* She thought bitterly. She had studied the ruins long ago…a beautiful crystal palace, a seemingly idyllic artist's work…She remembered strange inscriptions that their best linguistic computers could not decipher, as if the language itself refused to be understood. She remembered the beast that had murdered all her comrades and the flash brighter than the light of a thousand suns. On whom should I seek revenge? On a race that died out so absolutly so given it lost its name? The ones who are worshiped by the Anacites on Abbalon, though even the machines have forgotten who they were?" she thought, and glanced at Miss Daisy walking beside her. The woman was more gloomy and introverted than usual, which could be considered an interesting sight. But there was something else. It seems that that conversation brought back some unpleasant memories for her. *Does someone like her even have a jolly one?* Lashunti thought as she looked at the elf as she scared away the Shiren kebab seller with one look.

"What do you think of this elven wizard?" she asked, to break the tiring silence.

Miss Daisy snorted contemptuously

"She's an incompetent idiot... Noisy, and undisciplined. I've known students like that... I've had students like that when I've been

teaching." she shook her head and the witchwarper felt some of the anger escaped from the woman.

"Nantambu was a great school of magic on the Lost Golarion. It was one of the first schools of magic to be established in the post-Starfall era. If she's really from there... She might have a great deal of experience in magic to match yours." Lashunti said, remembering her... friend who had given her eyes. *Oh doctor, in all your millennia of life, have you ever been to that place? Did it still exist in your time?*

Miss Daisy answered her with a shrug.

"I don't know much about your Golarion, it meant nothing to me before i left my home planet, and now it's just somethimg that others miss, though knows it only from fairy tales brought to their world. I know there's usually a nasty truth behind these stories." she said grimly. "But I know someone who is said to be from that your Golarion... His name is Prince Zed and he's an Automaton.

Rechiza raised an eyebrow.

"Do you have one of them on Carurystal? I didn't know that even one survived to our times." she said, genuinely surprised.

"Yes. He was a great friend of Lady Cala's family, though our personal relationship is complicated." replied the sorceress

"Just like that... you have a complicated relationship with someone who remembers the times of Golarion...?!" Rechiza asked in disbelief.
Miss Daisy shrugged again.

"I don't understand what you all see in this old planet. It was neither technologically advanced nor particularly pleasant to live in, even if we believe the stories that always embellish reality. I know much more about thatthan I would like." she said with an energy that the witchwarper had never seen in her before.

"That's interesting... I was born on Castroval and spent a large part of my life in the Pact Worlds. I've been everywhere except maybe Aukturn." she said, and out of the corner of her eye saw Miss Daisy start. It didn't surprise her.

"What was your favorite place? The one that meant the most to you…" Miss Daisy suddenly changed the subject of the conversation.

She thought in surprise.

"Not counting Castroval? I spent a lot on Abbalon studying the ruins of the First Ones. Have you heard of them? " she looked at the mystic and saw that she had stumbled. She was clearly agitated, which she tried to hide.

"And what have you learned about this ancient and wise civilization?" the sullen woman asked.

"Not much on Abbalon. More during my travels, especially… while on Cracked Skull.-" she said after a moment's thought. She unconsciously looked away when she mentioned the planet where such a great tragedy had befallen her, but Miss Daisy noticed because she asked.

"And that's where you lost your eyes and antennae? The first guarded their secrets very jealously." said the grim sorceress, and the witchwarper sensed some sympathy in her voice, but she only felt fury.

"What would someone like you, someone from the backwaters of the galaxy, know about one of the greatest civilizations that ever inhabited the universe?"
Miss Daisy laughed very bitterly.

"Oh, what can I know... Absolutely nothing and more than you can imagine." she said smiling sourly. Rechiza frowned suprised. She didn't want to be surprised by someone like that.

"I didn't know you were interested in the history of the First Ones…" Rechiza asked, carefully examining the gloomy mystic.

"For many years ... I was in touch with their creation, one of the most perfect ..." said Miss Daisy. Lashunti had the impression that she sensed great sadness in her voice and ... something else? Guilty? Disgust? *The Grave Robber or someone like that* she thought. She knew many who had no problem looting places of worship and graves, perhaps Arkan-tar was such a person, but in the case of a dark sorcerer whom she suspected of colluding with cults, it could involve much darker deeds. *Is that where you got those scars from?* she asked in her mind, feeling for a moment a strange bond with that woman. Then she heard someone calling them.

- It's great that you're here! I was just looking for you! – Arkan-tar shouted.

She did not trust Rechiza, though perhaps a better word would be that she beware her. But Arkan-tar annoyed her. In Mystacor, she met many arrogant hustlers like him, who preferred to get what they wanted using their own cunning, rather than working hard for their success. "You, on the other hand, have been worked for your own downfall for decades..." she thought and smiled nastily.

"Why would someone so learned and resourceful wll need two sorcerers?" she asked with undisguised reluctance, but Verthani spread his hands in a gesture of helplessness.

"I need you because I have obtained important information, but I am unable to get it myself!" shouted the archaeologist.

"What important information our scholar has learned in the canteen over a beer."There was sarcasm in her voice, but Arkan-tar didn't seem to care

"Listen, I spoke to a former employee of an observatory, and they said they were scanning the Ravaged Zone. There may be maps

there that will corroborate what Lady Cala has provided us with." Verthani said smiling quite ingratiatingly. She thought for a moment. The maps they had were accurate, much more accurate than what they could reveal. Unfortunately, they were full of holes, because the cults of Nyarlathetop and other Great Old Ones and Outer Gods were not equally strong everywhere and did not always have someone capable of contacting Creeping Chaos. Besides, she wasn't sure if they could fully trust such demented people who would knowingly give their souls to such terrible beings. *Just because they're like you, you know what someone like you is capable of*

"I take it you don't need these maps to show that my Lady participation in this expedition is no longer needed?" she asked coldly.

"I would never leave you here if you sugest that. I would never have thought of such a thing, my lady." said the archaeologist spreading his hands."I'm not going to do that out of sheer laziness. It would take so much effort to figure out a way to board a ship secretly without your knowledge, and the Lady's company is very welcome for many reasons. Apart from the fact that we don't have a ship yet."

"We just got it, or rather we have the oportunity, to rent a ship with a crew. But they were interested in the presence of the Archaeologist and the Sholar on the ship." Rechiza interjected.

"They probably want someone to train the crew in matters of a more scientific nature, and perhaps teach them how to get around with a little better company." she said, seeing how Verthani's gray face faded when Rechiza mentioned that they needed an archaeologist. *Interesting*

"What kind of ship is this?" Arkan-tar asked cautiously.

"Well, we don't know much yet. It is own by a certain Bina and has such a funny sorceress to help." said Lashunti, grinning

happily. She tried to glare at her, but the Witchwarper didn't seem to mind.

"Okay Arkan, let's go there. You're right, it wouldn't hurt to find out more about where we're going. Just rent a car, 'cause this sun is killing me." she said, sighing heavily.

It took them a while to get transport, there weren't that many vehicles in this city, and even fewer people were interested in taking them out of town to this whole observatory thing. Finally, they found a small, horribly sheckening car with four hard seats in a cramped passenger compartment, where they had to sit facing each other, holding on to metal brackets hanging from the roof. The driver was a sullen and surprisingly menacing-looking Shiren. She smiled bitterly to herself when she saw the car. *Well, i am returning to old garbbage* she thought. In all the decades she'd spent in the Horde, she'd ridden a variety of vehicles, though she'd never learned how to drive them. At first she had an overwhelming aversion to noisy and clumsy machines, and then she had lost the ability to leave the Fright Zone anyway… But now she had come to appreciate Hordak's near-genius pragmatic ingenuitness, who could create such advanced machines with limited resources. *Who knows, maybe if you had somehow found your way to the Pact Worlds, you would now be a respectable if surly businessman, and I would be the respected Head Sorcereress of Mystacor,* she thought, feeling the vehicle tossing her with every bump. She thought about it. Virtually no one on Etheri knew how Hordak had ended up on her planet, including himself. Recently, however, she has got som suspicions. She was curious if anything had been concluded about this in her former home. But would anyone want to investigate a seemingly meaningless matter? Maybe her former superior would be interested, but she wasn't sure if he survived the final battle. In fact, she knew almost nothing about what happened after… her death, Creeping Chaos spared her information on this subject. They only told her that Catra and Adora had survived. She wasn't sure of anything else, not even if Glimmer was still alive, though

from some allusions made by Nyarlathotep she could hope... Apart from them and maybe Mikah and Castaspella, there were no people on Etheri whose survival she cared about. "But does anyone remember you without feeling hatred? Will anyone be happy to see you back?"
The grim tone of her thoughts must have begun to show on her face, because Arkan-tar turned to her smiling cheekily.

- Why are you so gloomy Miss Daisy? The two of you managed to capture a ship, which is a respectable act in a place like this. And you look like you've been ate lemon!

She began snapping her fingers, trying to prevent the vision of black tentacles strangling Verthani until his eyes popped out of their sockets.

"Mister Arkan-tar, I know from experience that easy beginnings do not ease future difficulties. We just had a bit of luck, and that's not something you should rely on. We must be absolutely focused and not let anything distract us if we are to survive!" *Do you hear what you're talking about again?*

"Well, someone who survived such a terrible accident has the right to see the future only in dark colors." Rechiza said with feigned sadness. She smiled at her, imagining the Lashunti shrouded in black flame. The archaeologist raised an eyebrow curiously, but before the witchwarper managed to say anything, she reached from behind her neck and turned off the mask. The two passengers sucked in a whistling breath. Arkan-tar's eyes widened in obvious shock, and Rechiza couldn't take her eyes off her face. She smiled at them, showing two protruding sharp fangs.

"There have been few in the last thirty years who have had the honor of seeing my face, so take a good look. - She ran a clawed finger over the scars.- This is only a fraction of the price I had to pay. And believe me, it was absolutely not worth it." she said sharply. "So I've learned to see the world as dark as possible, believe it or not, what you can't see will be much darker anyway.

"Then she put the mask back on. For a long time everyone was silent, which allowed her to return to her unhappy thoughts.

"Why are you doing this?" Lashunti finally asked in a softer voice than before.

{Why am I doing what?" she asked, startled out of her thoughts.

"Why do you serve Lady Cala and join this expedition with her?"

She thought for a moment. She had to come up with a safe answer, as close to the truth as possible, only she wasn't sure what the truth was.

:I guess I do it because I have to. Because I have nothing else to do." she said and realized it was true. Creeping Chaos would probably accept her refusal, then punish her in ways unimaginable. Most of what she did, she did to survive. She became an unrivaled master at this. *I was like a rat, clinging to life with all my claws... Ready to do anything to survive, betray anyone, hurt anyone.* In fact, it always just went with the flow, only paving the way with its claws. But once she did otherwise, and that's why she's where she is now. *I will do it this time too. I will do everything so that nothing happens to them. May no more misfortune befall them. That will be my personal goal, only in this way will I find redemption.*

"That's pretty fatalistic thinking." Rechiza said.

"Because I'm a fatalist ... What did this creature look like." she suddenly changed the subject.

Lashunti turned those strange, metallic eyes on her.

"How ..." she asked clearly shocked.

"I know a lot about the ruins of the First Ones, though most of what I know isn't first-hand… But I've seen creatures like this, and their power is potentially immense." Lashunti replied with a weak smile.

Rechiza shook her head.

"It was something like a solfuga... it took my antennae off, but... To get rid of it and hundreds of others that were in production, I used a rock incinerator- she said. She didn't know much about galactic weapons, but she guessed it must be something terrible, but she didn't pursue the subject. They have enough time to find out everything, so they spent the rest of the way in silence, thinking about what reasons led them to participate in this cursed enterprise.

***

You have been waiting for this chapter for a long time, although it is neither the longest nor the most dynamic.

Fallen Stars.

She looked at the falling stars smiling slightly. Being able to enjoy this view was one of the few perks of what the queen had done… what Glimmer had done. *She's not our queen anymore and she won't be if she continues act like this.* She thought as she looked at the small obsidian crown she had placed on the balcony table of delicate red stone. The crown was as black as her skin and had many sharp arms that shot upward like blades. She wasn't very impressive, not at first glance. It had no decorations, and no jewels were placed in it. Just a perfectly polished piece of stone. However, when someone looked at it, they could see that it absorbs light, as it does now, when it absorbed the glow of stars sparkling in the sky.

"Don't you find it strange, Neutrino, that we were called Stars sisters, even though we've never seen real stars? " Halo's voice came from behind her. She turned and said.

"No one saw them ..." she said and then corrected after thinking about it "Almost no one."

Her sister sat in an ornate wheelchair made from a converted chair made of wood that was harder than steel. Halo laughed sadly and looked at her. One eye still glowed with a red inner glow, but the other was gray and dead, as was the entire left side of her body. *A gift from the Shadow Weaver* she thought bitterly. The "living" half of her body was pinkish red and shiny, which further emphasized the enormity of the harm that the accursed sorcerer had done to her. Her fiery red hair was long and unkempt. She tried to take care of them herself, but it was not easy with one good hand. Besides, she often neglected her appearance, wallowing in her sadness and research.

"What are you writing?" she asked her sister, seeing that she was holding the nib in her hand, bent over a sheet of paper.

"Reply to the wedding invitation." She answered without stopping typing.

"It's the seventh. Now I think she'll understand that there's no point in trying again, and she'll stop the pathetic kindness." she twisted her mouth into a contemptuous smile.

"She'll stop it, because I'm writing that I agreed to come to the wedding, on my behalf and on yours as well." Halo said softly. Her voice wasn't as beautiful as it used to be, though it still had a certain melody to it. But the song within her was dark and full of pain

"Why? She continues to deny us our justice!" she shouted, and the whole balcony trembled with the strength of her voice.

"And he certainly won't give it to us if we sit on our islands as if we're hiding from the world. She should see what has been done to me. What has been done to us!" her sister's voice was enough to make her feel her own pain and rage, though it was only a shadow of what was in Halo's heart.

" Well, I'll have to order a new dress to made. I don't feel like wearing what I wore to Frosta's ball." she said before biting her tongue. Her sister experienced those events very bad, and she was not surprised. It's been since Glimmer's kidnapping that the war has flared up with renewed vigor... *And now we're going to damed Catra's wedding! Do they really not understand how absurd this is?!*

Halo only had full control over half of her face, but she smiled very serenely, which was extremely rare in the post-battle era.

"Everything will be fine, you have nothing to worry about. I have…good feeling." said gently the youngest of the Star Sisters.

"I'm glad..." she answered cautiously, unsure how to understand Halo's words.

"Really... I'm no longer the same scared woman who cowered in her own chamber for three weeks after that Scorpion blew up the pillars in the ice palace. No, my wounds have… healed." her sister touched the gray half of her face clumsily with a half-dead hand. She shuddered at the sight.

"Scorpion-woman will be there too. She is now a princess and married Perfuma." she recalled, sitting across from her sister.

"It could be fun. Scorpia is said to be a very nice woman. Sociable and open. I'd love to reminisce about the old days. I'll tell her some stories. You know about the battle and dark magic, about the fate of her relatives. You think she'll like them? And Perfuma... She loves beauty so much, so she'll have something to look at, won't she Neutrino?" Halo laughed bitterly loud and bitterly. She didn't like it when Halo was in this mood, and she'd been in it a lot lately. She could be very unpleasant then and could hurt others, even those who cared about her. But she wasn't going to talk her out of going to that stupid wedding. Let all see what has been done to them. *But they won't see everything, they won't see what happened to Pulsar* she thought bitterly.

"Well, this will be our little revenge." She smiled with a feeling of bitter triumph.

"The time for a big revenge will come to... "Halo smiled mysteriously.

"You think they'll give us Hordak eventually? We have nothing against Catra, so we should let her alone." he said thoughtfully, fearing where this conversation was heading.

"You know who I'm talking about!" Halo called out and stood up, leaning on her only good arm.

"She's dead!"she replied sharply to her sister.

"Because Adora and Catra say so?! They didn't even give us her body for us to spit on!" The youngest of the Star Sisters screamed

so loud that everyone in the ruby castle was now feeling a piercing pain.

"There is no body, because there is nothing left of her. With the release of such power ... We both felt it ..." Halo tried to calm down. She fell back into the cart, but seemed triumphant.

"We felt something different. I remember it as if a dark force beyond imagination reached here and took something. I'm telling you, Shadow Weaver is alive and laughing at us all!" Halo shouted, a little quieter this time.

"The dead are dead, that's one of those things that will never change." she said to her sister and put her hand on her shoulder. But she just gave a short, jerky laugh.

"Oh... If you'd seen it, I've seen it. You knew what I know." she felt what I feel. she said indulgently, as if to a child

She turned away from her so that Halo wouldn't see that she was afraid. She was worried about her. "Shadow Weaver, if only you were alive... If only you understood what you've done to us!" she thought, but answered her sister.

"Enough of this. She's dead, nothing can change that. You won't get your revenge. Forget everything and move on." she drawled to her sister, trying not to evoke the Voice of Terror.

"We'll see Neutrino. The future will bring the truth." Halo said quietly.

She couldn't talk to her sister anymore. Not when she was in that mood, which she was almost constantly. She stared at the falling stars for a moment. Reportedly, this phenomenon was much more common on Etheria, as the planet was in gravitational balance between the two suns and often passed between the outer clouds. She had heard that on other planets, their inhabitants considered shooting stars to be the tears of higher beings. Some even said that any wish made upon seeing this *tear* would be granted. I*f so, many must indeed weep for our planet... Or maybe*

we are the chosen ones of the universe and all our wishes will come true she thought and felt a cool wind. It was blowing from the southwest. From the Isles of Sorrow. "She came from there." She turned to her sister, who was drying a sheet of paper.

"I have to go. As far as I'm concerned, I agree to go to this damned wedding, too. I need to talk to Glimmer about how she envisions the future of our planet. Plus, there are a few people I like. Spinnrella, Prince Peekablue, even little Frosta, though she's not so little anymore... We swore to protect her, remember?" she asked Halo, who burst out laughing.

"Well, she's proven she can handle trouble, even when she brought it on herself. But it will be nice to see how she has grown and how she is doing. She's more powerful than ever. We've all gained power. But what lies there, there in this darkness above us." her sister said. "We don't know if we'll be able to defend ourselves again, even with She-Ra's help. They don't even know... But I'll be prepared." she said and looked into her eyes. There was a mysterious glow there, something that had not been there until recently. If it helps you, sister, she thought sadly. She walked over to Halo and gave her a tight hug.

"Take care, little sister. I'll come over to you before the wedding. I'll show you my dress and you'll tell me what needs to be improved. And don't forget your own dress… But now I must visit the Pulsar."

"Tell her I greet you. Believe me, he will understand. Hello said quietly." she left her sister in the ryby palace.

Since the end of the war, old Horde skimmers have revolutionized transportation. But she was using something much more interesting and… less reminiscent of Hordak and his cursed right arm. She smiled at the sight of the Galactic Horde's small captured gunboat. The ship was fast, elegant and stylish. Ship had reprogramed autopilot to listen to her voice, and she could fly it anywhere in Etheri, even take her into space. "Maybe that's a good idea." She thought as she entered the ship, which she had

painted in the color of gleaming obsidian. *To visit other worlds. To see something that none of us have ever seen in any of these lifetimes. Maybe then Halo would know that the Shadow Weaver wasn't lurking in the dark* she thought as the craft moved away.

In theory, there were four Star Islands, Obsidian, Ruby, and Pearl, and the Spire in between, but only the first three had true inhabitants. Each of them had belonged to one of the Starsisters for as long as the people of Etheria could remember. But the Spire was shared. Their legacy was kept there. Rising more than three hundred meters above the waves, the structure of black, red, and white stone was unmistakably the work of the First Ones. Entrapta wanted to examine her, but Hordak's mistress was forbidden to go anywhere near the Isles under threat of severe punishment... even the ultimate. They allowed Bow to see the remnants of that ancient civilization that lay on their islands, but not even he was allowed to approach the spire. The ship moored at the air harbor. They used to go here on Isle-manufactured magnetoflyaers and supplies were delivered to a second harbor just over the water. She was actually surprised how well the Galactic Horde's ship and the First One's building matched. One of her Custodians explained that there were a finite number of reasonable technical solutions, and she chose to believe him for lack of better answers. Someday she would have to look at this mystery, as well as many others related to their legacy, but that was the future, now she had to deal with something completely different ...

Guards clad in black, red, and white armor saluted her, raising their swords as she passed them. Those in white had their heads shaved as a sign of mourning for their lady. Those who served Halo, on the other hand, had the same feverish look as her sister. Once upon a time, all three of the Sworn Guards were among the mightiest armed formations on Etheria, but they suffered heavy casualties during the Battle. It took a long time to rebuild their strength, and in the case of the White Guard it was completely impossible for many years, until finally Pulsar began to accept their oaths again. What worried her the most was the condition of the Halo soldiers who seemed to share her sister's mental instability. She walked over to the narrow elevator that would take

her to the lowest level of the spire, which was deep below sea level. Above there were barracks, workshops and armories, as well as many rooms whose purpose was lost in the mists of time. They were used by the guardsmen and armorers from the Isles, but the undergrounds were the Star Sisters' private sanctuary, and only the Custodians were allowed to enter them outside.

The descent below the surface took a long time, and she felt as if she could feel the pressure of huge masses of water around her. The Custodians who came here had to stop to let their bodies get used to the pressure, but the Sisters were immune to it. As she stepped out of the elevator, she saw two Custodians who had come to greet her. The Custodian transformation ritual changed the appearance of those who submitted to it. They got taller and slimmer, and their eyes shone like one of the sisters, even though they weren't subdued to either of them. They renounced their names and pasts, even their facial features became similar. They always spoke to other in the third person and seemed to have no distinguishable personality. Ever since Prime's invasion, they had begun to make her uneasy, the islands with exception of Spire thoug hardly suffering from the invasion of a deranged conqueror. So she wondered what those who had met the Horde Prima in person must feel. "Maybe I'll invite Scorpia and Catra to the Spire, I'm sure they'll appreciate our servants and their pleasant company. They will remember the good old days." she thought smirking evilly.

There were always seventy-seven custodians, and they had numbers instead of names. When one died, the one with the previous number took the place of the predecessor. And then one of the inhabitants of the Isles would start dreaming of the Spire until he couldn't take it anymore and would come here to undergo the ritual and live the sometimes extremely long life of a Custodian. To some it may have seemed awful, but Etheria held many dark secrets. A few of them nearly wiped out their world.

The sanctuary was huge, with a ceiling that danced red, purple, and white lights. Even though they were deep underwater, the air was dry here. There were many tall pilars that wound together in

a spiral. Crystalline objects could be seen between the turns of the pilars. These were their predecessors, the Star Sisters from previous generations. However, the Pulsar was not placed there. Her fate was something they had not been prepared for in all the millennia since the First Ones had left.

Dressed in heavy tricolor robes, the custodians led her to a large altar carved to represent the first three Starsisters. Whenever one of them was injured or sometimes even killed, they were brought here and the ancient power of the First One's device healed them if it wasn't to late. It was something that almost no one on the planet knew about. She wasn't about to change this state of affairs. She wasn't sure if the device would help anyone else, and even if it did, it wasn't meant for strangers. *What have we done to deserve such an honor? We are only relics, remnants of a world that none of us even understood* she thought as she stood in front of her sister. Her body was shrunken and dry. She was in the fetal position with her eyes closed. Her whole body was covered with a strange growth, translucent and blue, which wanted to wrap around her sister's body and enclose it in a chrysalis. The Custodians removed it regularly, but it always came back. Nothing helped, although their resources were also limited. *Maybe if we brought She-Ra here, or Mikah, or even someone from other planet. Hell, maybe I'd let that mad girl examine her if she was sure would help Pulsar that way.* What was happening to her sister was seemingly no different from the fate that awaited them all. She seemed dead, but she was definitely alive, in some weird twisted way. She looked at the pillars and the crystalline objects within them. If you approached them, you could see that they were in fact bodies of the sisters of past... They weren't fully dead either, their successors could look into their memories if needed... When one of the Star sisters died, she created a crystalline cocoon in which it remained forever... And soon, within a few years at the most, her sisters joined her, overwhelmed with despair. And then the new Star sisters were born and the whole cycle started all over again.

But now it has been broken. Pulsar had been in this state for eighteen years. They lived, and she… As they approached, they

felt her constant pain, but for five years, since the Heart was dismantled something else too. The feeling of hunger, powerful and insatiable. She barely heard the plea, but it was poignant, heartbreaking with grief that made her knees buckle beneath her. She didn't know what her sister wanted, but she would do anything to satisfy it. But she had no idea what to do, she felt absolutely powerless. She knelt in front of her sister and said.- It's me, Neutrino. I hope you can hear me. It’s fine wit us. It's been almost five years since Horde Prima was defeated and peace reigned. We got an invitation to the wedding from our former queen. It's a double wedding, her and the royal techmaster Bow and this Catra’s and She-Ra’s. Or rather Adora’s. We refused at first, but Halo convinced us to agree. You know, I'm worried about Halo. Her obsession with the Shadow Weaver continues to intensify. He keeps saying that she's out there somewhere and hiding. That it's just waiting to come back and unleash her’s wrath. In fact, I wish it were. Then I could capture her, but I wouldn't kill her. I would have given her a much worse fate… You know what I mean. I would take her to the Savior. She would feel the same as we feel. She would understand what she did to you, to Halo, to me... What she did to all of us...

She smiled as she saw her sister leaving. She loved her very much, but she knew that she would never understand her. He would never feel what she felt, the incessant burning cold halfway through his body not passing even for a moment. None of her incarnations had known such a feeling. It was not only pain, but something completely unnatural, as if death itself had taken half of her body. Nothing could help her. Healers from all over Ethera came to heal her, but they couldn't even understand what was really wrong with her. After the war, they invited Horde medics, and even those few medics from the old Prime Empire, but they didn't do anything. She, She-Ra herself, had also arrived, but her presence only made things worse. She felt a little sorry for this Adora when she blamed herself for doing something wrong and hurting her. Though she saw the suffering in her eyes, she order her two more times, the last time nearly dying. Then the young

woman apologized to her and asked for forgiveness. Halo politely accepted the apology, but in her heart she felt hatred. For not being able to help her. For the false hope it gave her. For the fact that she was healthy and young and had her whole life ahead of her… Let her suffer, she no longer has compassion for others in her heart, except perhaps for her sisters.

But after all, she had felt better since the end of the war. She didn't toss and turn in her own bed at night. She did not lock herself in her own chamber, afraid to go outside. She didn't tremble at the sound of thunder. She found a new strength... But unfortunately she couldn't tell her sister about it. She wouldn't understand...

"Foundling, take me ... to the reading room" she called. From the shadows came a Prime clone dressed in a red livery. His hair was dyed red and slicked back. Neutrino didn't understand why she decided to make one of Hordak's brothers her personal servant, but she had nothing against clones. They had no choice, Hordak had, let alone his thousand-cursed right hand. They were just abandoned tools, as damaged as she was. She almost felt sorry for them. Almost…
The clone silently obeyed. He never said anything, he was probably a defect like the wicked ruler of the Dread Zone, but he was harmless. It was found abandoned on the beach of Ruby Island not long after they had returned from the Spire, where they had hidden behind a force field. For reasons that are difficult to understand, Prime didn't try to get the ancient building, but it's probably a good thing because thanks to the chipped Neutrino, the scales could tip to the other side...

The clone drove her to the reading room, then closed the door behind her. Then he pressed one of the red stones on the wall and a hidden passage opened. He drove her there. She found herself in a hidden tunnel that led to the vast and immeasurable dungeons beneath the palace. She discovered them soon after the War, when she heard the call, music that was painful in its truth. She promised… an end. The Foundling drove her to a dark room, her private sanctuary, then left her. She stood in front of a stone

altar she had had a trusted stonemason carve, then took a small book from a hiding place. She found it recently when she was searching the endless archives of Mystacor for anything that would help her find out how Shadow Weaver gained her powers and where she escaped... Unfortunately, she found no reliable information on this subject, although she had a vague feeling that the sorcerers were hiding something from her. But she found this book, and it contained the information she needed. She were explaining the call she had heard since the full power of magic had returned. The book was called the Gravedigger's Confessions, and it was about a being called Charon, the Horseman of Death, one of the Daemon masters. She lit two black candles and began to sing. It was the right moment, for Abbaxes's moon was now full. She suddenly felt an aura of unimaginable evil that almost made her vomit, and then she heard a voice.

"Welcom my Fallen Star… We have so much to talk about."

About grimoires and grim tales

She was sweeping the dust in a private bookcase, humming happily. She felt happy and excited. That glorious day was approaching. Her niece was about to get married! With that nice Bow! And Adora and Catra are getting married too! She was overjoyed that everything had worked out this way. Everyone was happy... Except...

She sat down in the chair feeling a surge of sharp sadness. *It must be difficult for him. It was an anniversary recently. Both anniversaries. His rescue and her…her death. Why do I not want to say that word even in mind?*

She put down the sweep and thought, resting her head on her hands. She was ashamed of it, but day of finding Mikah was one of the happiest days of her life, even though it was also the day the occupation began. The brother she buried, and whose presumed death had created a rift between her and Queen Angela, had returned. For many years, she could not forgive her for giving the order that led to that terrible battle in Valey of Shattered Armors sometimes known Scorpions Gorge. It wasn't until the meeting with Adora that her attitude changed, although she really decided to rejoin the alliance only after Glimmer was kidnapped. She missed the Battle of Brightmoon, but tried to make her and her sorceres participate in the war struggle. So she didn't have much time to talk to her sister-in-law. And then... She left. They never had a serious talk about the Battle, Mikah's fate, and what they should do next. The portal was… it was something difficult to describe, each of them experienced it, although most did not say what they experienced there. It wasn't easy to accept the truth about herself revealed by the perfect world of that reality... She remembered what her perfect life looked like and shuddered... No, she didn't want to go back to that one. *We don't live in a perfect world, but it's not that bad, it's definitely better than what it used to be.* She smiled sadly to herself. *Maybe I'd better go get some air? Maybe it will drive away dark thoughts?*

So she got up and left the small apartment that had been her home for so many years.

Mystacor has returned to its former glory in the five years since the end of the war. It even grew because sorcerers from all over Etheria came here. No one made it difficult for them to travel all over the planet anymore. No one was in danger of being killed by enemy soldiers anymore if he crossed the border. No one had to hide behind fortress walls and in refugee camps to escape the war. Not even this Lonnie with her People's Rebellion bothered the common people of Etheria as they traveled. She saw hundreds of people strolling within the ancient walls of the college. They were not only young students who came every year to learn magic, but also many adults, sometimes older than her, who only now had the opportunity to study. There were even former soldiers and technicians of the Horde who had never had the opportunity to discover their talents before. *Though then probably many would prefer that no one found out about the power dormant in them ... No ... that Shadow Weaver did not find out* she thought and shivered again. The Dark Sorceress might have sent someone like that to Beast Isle, though in theory such an order would have to be approved by Hordak, and he often refused her…if he saw it at all. But even without that, Shadow Weaver had her ways of making someone disappear or have a terrible accident happen to them." she thought as she passed some Vaste, who supposedly spent most of his life simply extracting ore from deposits located in the Horde's territory, until he decided that magic could be responsible for the strange things that happened to him and he was right! As she passed him, he nodded to her, and she responded with a warm smile. *Yes, it's one of those sights that reminds us why we fought and how wonderful the victory we won was* she thought, and walked to the cloudy beach where she met the most special student she had seen in many thousands of years. They name was Aize and they were from Eridani, one of the planets conquered by the Horde that had survived the occupation relatively well... They was the Empress's servant, and during her first visit to that planet, Glimmer had discovered talent in them. On many other planets of the Prime’s Empire, magic was

weak, sometimes even considered a fairy tale. Eridani was somewhat of an exception, as most of the inhabitants had innate, if limited, magical abilities.

"Hello, Aize! Isn't the beach beautiful? I remember Glimmer always trying to take the opportunity to hang out here, as did Bow, Adora. Of course, most students like this place… Well, it's often crowded now, after the war, because so many new students have arrived!" she said delightedly, until she noticed that with each word she spoke, the young person became more and more overwhelmed.

"I ... I'm actually here because I'm drawing moons, because I need it. You understand, Head Sorcereress Castaspella, there is no sun here, and I need it." They said, trying not to meet her eyes. She was short like most of the inhabitants of the planet, her planet, her skin was grayish pale and her hair dark. It looked like she was made of ashes and charcoal. She was dressed in gray-brown robes. Most of the inhabitants of Eridani looked similar, apart from those living underground, who were slightly different ... And of course there were a few golden-haired and winged nobles, and apparently there were others in the vast and dark forests, but as far as she knew, they had no desire to associate with their cousins. They all resembled the inhabitants of the planet Bellum, but were supposedly not related to them, which was good for everyone.

"Ah, the sun! Well, it seems like Celesta or Nirvia would be the most suitable…they're moons of enchantment, you know that? Give power to Mystacor... His defense spells and many more." she said, pointing to the moons.

"Yes, the Head sorceress Castaspello. Professor Split told meabout it… though…" Aize hesitated

"Yes?" she asked her, looking at the clouds shining in the moonlight. *It really is beautiful.*

"Why do you use the power of only three moons and not all the others?" she said while looking away as if she might be punished for being too curious.

"It's a very old and grim tale! "she said, trying to get in the mood to make the story sound right.

"From the time of the First "nes?!" Aize asked curiously, forgetting about her shyness for a moment.

"Uhhh, no. Not so long ago. Absolutely ..." she said, out of rhythm. "Mystacor and the other colleges have been built a many..." She didn't finish as Aize interrupted her again.

"Are there other colleges? Could i see them? Are there also so many students there?" they asked, her big eyes getting even bigger.

"Uhh, they're no mor. That's what this story will be about…" she took a deep breath after being interrupted once again. She liked telling stories, and she was great at it, but it was hard when no one was letting you finish them! "There used to be three schools. Mystacor, Arkanacor and Umbracor. All three taught magic, but each in a different way. We at Mystacor focus on developing individual talents and finding our own style. Arkanacor, in turn, was focused on studying the theory, understanding what magic itself is. Umbracor was interested in ... development, in questioning established rules. They were experimenters and seekers of truth! " she spoke with slightly closed eyes, and the Eridian person listened to her, and it seemed that she had no intention of interrupting her.

"But as the centuries passed, the differences in how they perceived magic grew. Everyone saw differently how future sorcerers should be shaped. They tried to win over the princesses and local community leaders to send them their students. The competition grew! They began to resort to increasingly brutal methods to gain recruitment grounds. The sorceres began to get involved in politics and influenced the rule of the princesses, and

some even began to believe that they, as the true magic wielders, should rule over all of Etheria! - she called and made a theatrical pause so that the listeners, that is Aize, could digest the enormity of horror that was hidden in what she said. The effect, however, was lost the moment there was a loud snort behind her. She jumped and turned sharply. She saw Catra smiling mockingly, Melog sitting next to her staring at her with feline curiosity.

"Once upon a time I would have applauded that sorcerer with all my heart." she said, and then added. "And if Mermista throws me into the water again trying to extinguish what Sea Hawk set on fire, I'll think about studying here myself.

Aize, who was hiding behind a bush when Catra appeared, came out for a moment.

"So Grand Marshal Catra will now be Grand Sorceress Marshal Catra!" exclaimed the Eridian person in a mixture of horror and delight.

"Er, no... I've never had the slightest talent for magic, and even if I had any, I'd rather shave my tail than go this way... I have bad enough experience with sorcerers that I don't trust most... Aside two." she said thoughtfully, and then suddenly she realized, what she said and looked at her." I like you too, Castaspella. "There was an apologetic tone in her voice. *She trust Mikah and Glimmer but not me, but why should she if I don't trust her?* she thought. Unlike her brother and niece, she never fully forgave the girl. That she had kidnapped Glimmer, that she had tried to kill her niece many times, and that it was her fault that Angela had left before she could talk to herself about everything.

There was an awkward silence. Melog grunted nervously, looking around. Catra stared at her feet, clearly confused. Her hair was long again now, but tied together in a wild ponytail and she wear a red vest.

She decided to smile at the girl gently and said trying to change the subject.

"Oh, you wear the socks from me!" she exclaimed with exaggerated joy. *If Glimer and Mikah could forgive her, then I should at least try.*
"Yes, they are very warm ... And these holes somehow made themselves. You know claws and stuff." she smiled nervously.

"So... what brings you here?" she asked, trying to keep the conversation going. The Grand Marshal sighed heavily and took a candle from her pocket.

"You know, the anniversary is coming up, but I'm going to be a little busy with the wedding this year, so I decided to come a little early." she said and laughed nervously.

Yeah, it's that day too She reminded herself. Catra used to come here every year on Victory Day to light a candle in front of the Light Spinner statue... its mean the Shadow Weaver... *Why couldn't you stick to one name? Or not toy with such disgusting power at all? And why am I thinking about her again? She didn't even like me...*

"You know, if you'd let me know earlier, I'd have found a few people who still remember her. Maybe you could talk, reminisce…" she said and immediately realized she had made a gaffe. Catra, however, made a grim face and said, crossing her arms over her chest.

"She's not really a person I want to remember... And believe me, no one knew her as well as I did. Not you, not Mikah, not even Adora." she was clearly agitated, but tried not to show it. She extended her claws and pursed her lips, Melog lay down on the ground touching her feet with his muzzle. Then she smiled expectantly, knelt down to stroke Melog, and then reached for the bag she had on her shoulder. She took out a strange book from there. On the cover it had black amorphous shapes wandering among joyful… or frightened people. She shuddered.

"Shadow Weaver would love to read it." she said quietly to herself, but the Grand Marshal heard her.

"I said the same thing to Mikah when I saw her, and he said that I wish Shadow Weaver had seen it, because everything would have turned out differently.So I decided to bring it here to your library to be copied, because it comes from the collection of Bow's fathers, it's supposed to be the only copy. It's called "Thousand of Thousand Masks" and it tells some creature called "Na..." something and ..." Catra didn't finish, because Aize groaned aloud.

"Nyarlathotep Grand Marshal Catra. The Great Outer God…" they said, looking at Catre with a mixture of fear and awe. She looked at her clearly confused.

"How do you know about him? Oh, we probably have a second one..." she wanted to say, but the Eridian woman shook her head violently.

" No… I saw another copy... in a hidden library in the Undergrounds... On Eridani. We hid many valuable books there from being destroyed by Horde Prime... But then some cultists stole it and... - " rhe student was very agitated. They looked from Catra to her, as if they expected some reaction from them, but she had no idea what they meant...

"It means... That this book dates back to before Etheria was hidden in Despondos!? " she said as the meaning of the young Eridian's words hit her. She felt astonishment turn into excitement in her heart. *This may be the oldest book in the world, and we discovered it. Lance and George will be delighted to have it in their collection she thought happily.* She couldn't wait to read what was written by an author living in the time of the First ones.. *Maybe we'll learn something about what happened to the First Ones. What was their civilization like… Why did they do all that to their planet…* she smiled thinking about it all, but then looked at Aize. They looked from her to Catra with wide-eyed fear.

"You... You really don't understand anything, do you? Well, you don't know anything about such things…" said the Eridian person, suddenly dazzled.

"What things do we not understand? " Catra asked sharply. She was smiling indulgently, but wagged her tail hard, and Melog had his ears pricked up. They were as concerned as the Eridian.

"his book is not that old... Or much older than anything we know, whichever way you look at it. Nyarlathotep and the Other Outer Gods... Great Old Ones like Great Cthulhu... They are older than the universe and mighty beyond all imagining." they spread her hands helplessly, as if they couldn't find the right words to describe what they wanted to tell them.

Suddenly she understood what the student meant.

"Ah, they are something like Iomdi and Sereni that you worship!" she exclaimed happily, but then Aize looked at her indignantly.

"No... They're something completely different. Even Asmidian and Urgatia hate them, and they are also terrible..." the gray-haired person was clenching her hands on the amulet depicting flaming wings. *Yeah, they had their heroes too, whose memory they venerate... Actually, their Iomdi could be some sort of memory of a previous She-Ra'i. That would explain a lot.*

"Ah, I understand... But such stories should not be taken quite seriously... Many times in recent years we have found out..." she didn't finish, because Catra called her.

"These aren't just stories. " The Great Marshal's voice was full of anxiety. A girl approached, holding a book open, anxiously staring at the illustration. It depicted a black amorphous being crawling out of a portal somewhere in the ceiling. It had countless four-lobed eyes and tentacles ending in hands, and a huge, wide-open mouth. There were two figures at the bottom, and the creature was reaching for it. She felt cold sweat bead down her back. She'd heard of the creature from Mikah's stories, but she'd also seen a similar, if less graphic, drawing in Araxia.

"Eater of Light - Avatar of Nyarlathotep…" Catra read it and winced - That's how Mikah described it, he even folded the page

on this page.

"He never respected books, especially those that are valuable." she said a bit unconsciously, and then turned to Aize ?Come on, tell us, did your book have the same illustrations?" she called, the Eridian groaned loudly and came to them, though it looked as if someone was about to hurt them. She stood beside them, but as Catra turned the book over, the student squeezed her eyes shut.

"Don't be afraid, a book can't hurt you." she said in a reassuring tone. The Eridian gave a desperate laugh.

"Of course they can. It may not be The Book of Dead Names or The King in Yellow, but I don't feel like looking at those pictures." they said, but contrary to her words, she opened her eyes and became so pale that her skin was as white as the dead.

She-Ra's fiancée nodded thoughtfully and turned a few pages. There was another illustration, this time of a tall and thin man clad in black tights with an inverted Ankh on his chest. His head was wreathed in flames resembling a crown, and his eyes glowed with an inner glow, though she ha a faint impression that there was an indescribable evil hidden inside them. Above the image was the inscription *Karsai called The King. Keeper of the Divine Planet Aukt*urn Catra slammed the book shut violently, and Aize sighed loudly with relief. She did the same, only a little quieter.

"Well, I guess we'll take it to the library, then. They'll scan it there, copy it, and lock it up in a secured section." she said, trying to sound cheerful. Catra nodded, clearly concerned, and Melog's "hair" stood on end. She understood them well, she herself felt uneasy after looking through the book. No doubt that was something very Shadow Weaver liked, she thought.

"Yes, we'll take her back together, I've never seen your library, and maybe I'll find something interesting for Glimmer to get her away from wedding preparations for a moment, because she'll pass out at her own wedding." Catra said and brought a sad smile to her face

She had never been sure of her feelings for *Auntie Casta* as Glimmer called her. She was with no doubt a kind and good woman, but she and Melog always sensed that she was tense around her. They had never met…before she had returned from Velvet Glove, but she understood what the Head Sorcereres of Mystacor might hold against her. It's mostly because of her that she's missing... It's because of her that Queen Angela died. Glimmer and Mikah somehow forgave her, though she didn't understand why, but Castaspella never forgot what she had done. She was always polite and kind to her, even once gave her socks in which she had to cut out places for claws, but there was always an invisible wall of ice between them. *But at least she doesn't want to send me to Beast Island like Lonnie imagined* she thought with a wry smile. Bow had once told her that not everyone would like her, even good people might dislike her company, and vice versa, she didn't have to like everyone, and that didn't make her any worse than anyone else. But she had to admit that the Head Sorceress was trying very hard not to show her dislike and not letting resentment cloud her judgment. Now they were carrying this strange book to the library, and she had a feeling that their cooperation would not end there, because they only had the first piece of the Shadow Weaver's puzzle. *Will I ever be free of this bitch? Even when she is less than a shadow, she still haunts us all… But maybe it's better that we do it before the wedding so that I don't think about her when I swear my undying love to Adora.* She smiled to herself at the thought. she bumped into one of the students who jumped away from her and apologized profusely- It's okay, I should be careful too! - she said, trying to smile friendly, but in her heart she felt a bit of pride that even in distant Mystacor she aroused respect. But then she almost bumped into another student again. "Why are there so many of them here? Glimmer always said it was a quiet and cozy place where life flowed slowly" she thought. Now she felt like she was wandering the Fright Zone on combat alert, though she had to admit that it smelled much better here.

She looked at the student from Eridani... She think her's… they's name was Aize. She followed Casaspella, who was paving the way for the little person. She decided to strike up a conversation.

"I think we've met before... Do you remember? On board the Darla when we brought you from Eridiani." She tried to sound as friendly as possible. The Eridian jumped back in fear as she spoke to them.

"Indeed Grand Marshal Catra." The student pronounced they name and title so that it sounded like one word. She had never been addressed that way in the Horde, not with such reverence. She already understood how Adora felt when the people she met had treat her as living legend. Only unlike her fiancée, she was fine with it.

"So I guess we've gotten to know each other a bit. - she said, although she could hardly remember what the Eridian person had been doing then, but she had some work to do then, working out a plan for joint military exercises and listening to Glimmer moans after the Empress's party.

"I ... I did not leave the room offered to me, so as not to disturb the peace of the Invincible warrior, Great Commander and Heavenly Queen." The student replied in a tone as if she was apologizing for something. *Sometimes, however, this reverence can be quite disturbing;*

"Whew... how do you know so much about all these books? I didn't know such matters were discussed at the Empress's court." she asked, though the possibility that the court in Eridani was engaged in discussing the dark books on a daily basis brought to mind things she preferred not to think about.

"I worked at the Hidden Library and there I saw a lot of books that were hidden from Prime in hidden vaults. I spent most of my life there looking after books. In fact, they were my only friends. - though I never met them all." Aize said in a happier and less scared voice than before.

„Ugh…. That explains a lot”, she thought, and continued. "And these cultists have stolen the book? Is she hiding some dark secrets?"
Eridian shook they head.

"No, not much, but they were worshipers of Nyarlathotep, for them it is sacred! This will undoubtedly encourage them to do more evil deeds."

"Wait, but you worship Iomdi and Sereni, so what are they worse than you…" she asked with a corner of her smile. The short personl looked at her with her big eyes as if she had just said that she strangled they pet.

"Don't compare that... Nyarlathotep is something else, not even evil, but completely alien! And I worship Iomdi and Sereni, for they are the personification of light and peace! - they shouted loudly, causing several students to turn to them.

" If you say so... But you better not say it out loud, because such words bring to mind Horde Prime. Some people might get offended…" she said sharply, maybe a little too sharply. But just like Shadow Weaver, everything about Horde Prime brought back terrible memories for her. Melog grunted loudly, and she felt the anger radiating from him, aimed at both Aize and her. She frowned as she looked at her companion. Her relationship with Melog was very complex and difficult to describe. Melog could speak to her with complex concepts and images, but it was difficult and tiring for him, as if he was speaking in a completely foreign language that he did not fully understand. He preferred to communicate through the emotions and feelings that they could pass on to each other. *Perhaps I was too harsh, but they should be carefull. Etheria has suffered much at the hands of that Horde and should not speak of anything that might evoke the memory of Him.* Then she saw the picture. Iridion, capital of Eridani. A quarter of the city lay in rumble, destroyed after the surrender, although the inhabitants of the empire did not resist. Prime did it just like that, on principle. She saw the half-burnt edifice of the building where Sereni was worshipped. A statue of her was

spared. However, he was deprived of his eyes, mouth and wings. A statue of Horde Prime towered over it, a fiery mace in its hand. *Yes, many planets suffered much more than Etheria under the occupation, I understand that, but it doesn't change the fact that she should be careful what they says and keep certain opinions to themself* she tried to tell him, but her companion didn't seem satisfied.

She'd known they were near the library long before she'd seen the great door with the Mystacor symbol on it. Somehow the library wasn't destroyed, apparently Horde Prime thought chiped mages might need it. As they crossed the gate, Aize smiled at the sight of all those scrolls and books. They tried to copy everything they could into the computers, but it will still take years to transfer everything. Bow's Father's library might have held rarer volumes, but it was no match for size.

"Do you have any books here at all that aren't about magic and stuff like that?. she looked around in bewilderment.

"Oh, I didn't know you liked books. Bow probably instilled in you a love of literature, and he did the same with Glimmer. He was a very lively child..."

"When I was a child, I didn't like to read, but Adora loved novels, so I thought we could read something together." she said.

"You had books in the Horde?" asked Castaspella, genuinely astonished. She sighed at Glimmer's Aunt words.

"Yes, they were regularly delivered to us cadets. Mostly by the caretakers and instructors, but sometimes Shadow Weaver brought them. These were mostly tales of brave soldiers of the Horde fighting against the soulless tyranny of the princesses. They weren't very good, in the end I told Adora that they only differed in the names of the characters, sometimes even whole scenes were repeated, as if someone made them ... from a stamp? Is that what it says here? And then when I took over… it turned out that I was right. They had whole formulas for novels there, which

they simply filled with content." she described, immersed in memories.

"You had… literature factories?" Castaspella said shocked. She nodded her head thoughtfully.

"Residents needed entertainment, simple and easily accessible. And Hordak banned the sale of alcohol... Of course, no one cared, the technical department was selling a lot of vile moonshine. No, I didn't drink it, maybe once or twice... Shadow Weaver, on the other hand, was a strong drinker, especially after failed experiments... But she brought us better novels. When we were little, she even read them to us… She had a collection of fairy tales, very nice, but quite unusual. You know, it's weird to remember that sometimes she was tolerable. - he sighed, feeling a surge of strange nostalgia ... "I found it in her private rooms ... but it turned out that it was written in her native language, which they use on the Isles of Sorrow. I must have it translated by the Bow's Fathers. I wish I could read them to our..." she realized that she had said a bit too much, that she had exposed her inner self to others. - Then let's take this book, because I still have a lot to do before the wedding, and you know, I'm a grand marshal…" She tried to change the topic before Castaspella realized what she had almost slipped away, but the Head Sorcereress looked at her in delight.

- Oh, it means that you and Adora think ... I always expected that Bow and Glimmer would be the first, because the boy grew up in a large family. - Castaspella beamed with joy, Aize stepped back a bit overwhelmed by the whole discussion. Catra flattened her ears at the sudden outburst of tenderness, and Melog clung to the floor.

"Maybe we shouldn't look that far into the future. It's just... just a random thought. We have some problems to solve... which even with the help of Prime's technology can cause trouble.." She felt her face turn red.

"Adora's ancestry..." Aunti Casta suddenly nodded in understanding.

"Not just Adora’s... But please don't tell anyone about this, I haven't talked to anyone about it, not even Adora, and her opinion and desires are in that cause as important in this. Therefore, for now, let it stay between us ... " she looked around "and between Aize ... Library employees ... But I think I would really give this book away." She smiled nervously.

"And what were these stories about?" the Eridian person asked unexpectedly. She looked at her surprised, but gladly changed the subject to something less embarrassing.

"There were stories about Aroden fighting the Whispering tyrant, the sorcerer with the face of a skeleton, the terrible Lamashutu, the fearless Besmara, the brave Cayden…" After each name Aizen's eyes widened more and more "Did something happen?"she asked the student, fearing another outburst of indignation.

"Nothing, absolutely nothing!" The Eridian person replied, slightly frightened, and began to look around the library, apparently unsure of what to do with herself. Castaspella engaged in a conversation with several library employees about transferring books to computers, so she will took the opportunity to return the cursed book so that she could light the candle under the statue of the cursed sorcereress in peace.
***
I ended up splitting this chapter into two smaller ones because it grew mercilessly.
I am asking for comments and remarks, I am very interested in your opinion.

Something is rotten in Mystacor

Night Gale was ordered to follow the Head Sorceress, which wasn't that hard. Castaspella wasn't a very observant person, so it wasn't difficult. Unfortunately, her lack of perceptiveness was leading to a problem.

It was extremely difficult to protect her, but that was her main goal. She was entrusted with this extremely important task and she could not fail. It worked to her advantage that they were both competent sorcerers, though neither was a warrior. Of course, Castaspella had been a hero of the rebellion for nearly twenty years and a member of both alliances. She had to be able to defend herself. Though as she watched the woman nag about nonsense with this weird person from Eridani, she wasn't so sure. After all, she wouldn't have been given this mission if it wasn't needed. Though as a servant of Crawling Chaos, you'd have to be prepared for lies within lies. That was the price of power, and she was willing to pay it.

However, she had a second task, or rather Scarlet had it. Lonnie gave her the mision of infiltrating Mystacor and possibly getting the wedding plans, as the head sorcereress of Mystacor was helping Glimmer organize the wedding, and Comrade General was praparing something special for the occasion, but unfortunately she didn't share it with Scarlet, she thought she didn't trust her, although she did she really didn't even suspect the truth about who her sorcereress actually was.

She didn't even know what identity Scarlet had taken in Mystacor to be able to stay here safely. She suspected she was one of the many guards who kept order at the sorceres school. Well, her cover was much better.

"Oh! Night Gale, great to have you back!" cried Professor Split, a slightly obese satyr and lunarology teacher. A somewhat clumsy individual, teaching the most useless aspects of a subject that had the potential to be one of the most important in the entire

academy, even a key field of magic on Etheria ... *But of course, instead of focusing on important matters, the people of Etheris allowed themselves to be distracted by a false sense of triumph., pathetic*

"How can I help you? " Night Gale smiled kindly at the professor.

"As you know, the Head Sorceress Castaspella has been busy with wedding preparations lately, so she's been neglecting her duties a bit." said the Lunarology teacher. She felt her pulse quicken. "It would be the perfect position to fulfill my tasks as both Night Gale and Scarlet. Being Castaspelia's secretary or assistant, she will always be close to the Head Sorcerer and all documents will always be within my reach." She smiled slyly to herself.

"So, I would ask you to help me take care of my students… you could even lead the lessons for a while." I listened to you discuss with Master Skygazer and it was a wonderful exchange of views. - he said smiling at her. She clenched her teeth, too sharp compared to those of most creatures like her. *So even you have realized the uselessness of your classes?* she thought and turned to the overweight Satyr, looking down at him. As Night Gale, she was taller than most people she encountered. She was one of the few who could look Scorpia straight in the eye, though of course she was no match for her strength... But she had other skills... She walked over to the professor and looked at him with concern, reaching for the bit of power she had been given.

"Something happened?" he asked anxiously.

"No, absolutely nothing... But I'd advise you to take care of your liver, because when I look into your eyes..." she tutted and shook her head anxiously.

Split turned pale and walked away from her, probably to go to his apartment and look at himself in the mirror or go straight to the healer. *Problem Solved But you gave me a great idea, I should have thought of it myself* thought Night Gale, and cursed softly as she turned to see Castaspella talking to Catra. The Grand Marshal

was one of the few people she should avoid. She wasn't sure if she could smell her true nature. So she decided to watch them from a distance for now, waiting for an opportunity to get closer to the Head Sorcereress. She had enough time. Night Gale had a lot of time, her job was to archive reports of magical weather phenomena. She came to Mystacor once every two weeks and spent a few hours turning the scrolls. She worked as a volunteer, so no one investigated the quality of her work, and she had an excuse to move freely around the university. Night Gale had never gone to college, but she didn't want to bring up her past in the Horde, it would raise too many questions and draw attention to her, and Night Gale needed to remain as invisible as possible to perform tasks for both of her employers. Of course, only a handful knew of her true past in the Horde, and she didn't want to add too much truth to this so convenient identity. So she came up with that she came from the borderland between the Crimson Wastes and Brightmoon. She was to be trained by a litle known sorcerer, Master Iriam, a loner who died during the occupation. Iriam was a real person she had stayed with for some time after leaving the Fright Zone. She even liked him and thought he was a decent person, but he discovered the truth about her… *Don't think about the past because it distracted you. An important task awaits you, requiring absolute focus. Remember the reward…* she chided herself mentally.

Catra and Castaspela, and this strange Eridian person, were talking agitatedly about some book, but she was too far away to see what it was about. Scarlet had never told her that the feline was interested in literature, but she had never been their favorite topic of conversation. Lonnie also never implied that her biggest rival liked to read, even she talked a lot about her. What she saw was interesting. Then the three of them left, and she followed them. After a while she guessed they were going to the library, so she smiled to herself. There, it will probably be easier to talk to Castaspella among these countless bookcases, shelves and alcoves….

Visiting the library was something that happened to other people, not to mention bringing books. She felt… Strange, like she was trying to put herself in someone else's skin. She had felt this way the last time she had gone shopping with Bowe. She was glad that the library was so large, because it allowed her to avoid being too crowded. Usually she could turn invisible with Melog's help, or simply by sneaking through the shadows like she did in the Fright Zone, but now she was standing in line behind the Mystacor students, waiting until she could scan the book. She was sure that with one word she could make them split up and leave the library or even lock themselves in their rooms. If she put in the effort, she might be able to persuade them to leave Mystacor at all. She just wasn't sure if it would be because of who she was or who she had become. The apprentices and sorceress looked over their shoulders at her and whispered among themselves, thinking she couldn't hear their words full of fear and delight. *That's her! Hordak's Former Right Hand. Is She-Ra Here Too? She's a hero. She saved her. She's terrifying..* She sighed heavily. *Maybe Castaspella or Aize could give me this book? And I would finally light that candle* But they were just beyond her reach. Castaspella was busy talking wit other sorceres who wanted her to decide on some matters related to the administration of the academy. Where Aize was, she had no idea. She sighed and waited, the line moving slowly, incredibly slowly. It felt like hours before she finally got to the end. It turned out that the scanner operated a Reptile-person. When he saw her, he stood at attention. *Yeah, Horde technician. I should have expected it, after all, who else is operating the scanners and library computers*

"Welcome Seccond in Command Catra... That is Grand Marshal Catro..." he said and saluted. She sighed and said.

"Yeah… well, could you scan that book?" she smiled imploringly. "Relatively quickly?"

The library lab blinked a few times.

"Well, i cannot ... " he answered her and did not even move. It took her a moment for his words to sink in.

"Why?" she asked, trying to control her voice.

Well, I can't scan it." he replied calmly.

"Why?" she asked coldly.

"Scanning, copying, or borrowing of books from Mystacor's Great Library requires mebership of sorcerers guild or permission from one of Mystacor's masters or three different professors. Then you have to submit an application and after considering it, it is possible to share…

"But I'm not going to borrow anything." she interrupted him. "I want to deliver a new book so that it can be copied and placed in the library." she replied with hope in her voice.

The technician thought.

"Then you have to apply first…" he started to explain, but she didn't let him finish.

"How long have these rules been in place here?" she asked, getting a little suspicious "There are a lot of former Horde techs working here and we thought it would be worth organize things up a bit, so we launched a petition to change the rules and it was approved few months ago." the former Horde technician said it proudly, as if he was talking about his greatest success. She felt her eyelid twitch in anger.

Shadow Weaver, you are worse than the plague. You have infected the entire Horde with yourself, and now the infection has spread throughout Etheria. Our grandchildren will suffer the consequences of your actions and plans. Even though you're dead, I see you everywhere. Your bloody legacy will outlast us all. If you weren't dead, you could be proud of yourself she thought and felt like howling in helplessness.

"Where can I get this permit? Where can I submit this application? DO ANYTHING TO GET AWAY FROM THESE TENTACLES OF MADNESS!" she screamed loud enough to be

heard throughout the library. Melog flashed bright red, growling menacingly. The Reptile Person stared at her for a moment, blinking slowly. unfazed, he reached under the desk and handed her a four-page document. She didn't even care how much time she would have to waste on filling it out. She absolutely didn't care.

"Can I get something to write with?" she asked in a tired voice.

The technician smiled and handed her a pen… On a chain. Keeping her face absolutely stone-faced, she extended her claws and in one quick movement cut the chain, smiled and walked away with the papers.

She found a secluded spot and started going through the papers. She sighed at the name. *Who in Etheri even used surnames besides the Horde and people like Glimmer? And why Horde was doing it? It was definitely not Hordak's idea, because for him the very idea of having his own name was something new.* She thought for a moment about leaving the space blank. Her full name sounded cute, Bow said, but he didn't know where it came from. Catra Applesauce Meowmeow. That sounded sweet and silly, and Adora was sure, and somewhat ashamed, that she had thought it up. Recently, an official told her that as a two-year-old, she just walked all over the Fright Zone saying Applesauce and pointing at herself meowing like a little kitten. Sauce, or rather applemousse, was one of the few sweets available in the Horde. It was distributed in tubes, but the cadets never got it out of concern for their teeth. Several days in a row, she walked among the officials, asking them for her dream delicacy. She got that stupid name instead. A few years later, I managed to steal her coveted treat, she found it nasty. She had no sweet taste. Half the day she lay crying over the injustice of the world. *I guess that sums up my whole life. I've always wanted something, and then when I got it, it didin't bring me happines* she thought bitterly, then remembered something. Soon after the war, she discovered whipped cream and it became her favorite treat. Well, she liked

greasy food. They decided that their wedding cake would be covered with whipped cream. Castaspelia needs to be reminded of this, or she'll forget about it in all the fuss” she thought, and looked at the application. She managed to fill about half of it. That's enough for now, she thought, and went to look for the Head SorcereressAs she walked through the shelves, she smelled a scent. A scent she knew well know...

Melog bristled... She began sniffing around the wall of the Great Library. *A corpse, there's a corpse here somewhere...* she thought. *A corpse in safest part of Mystacor, ithe safest place on Etheria*. The hair on the back of her neck stood up, as did her companion's. She felt that very primal instincts were awakening in both of them. She started tapping on the wall, full of very bad forebodings. *That's how I found Entrapta once. After so many hours in the ventilation tunnels, it smelled so bad that even Scorpia could smell it, but it was still a lot better than what I smell now. It must lie here for a good few days, but no longe*r she thought. Finally, she heard a hollow sound, probably no one who did not have such sensitive hearing would not be able to notice anything. She groped the wall, glad that searching the nooks and crannies of the Fright Zone and stealing the officers' belongings had taught her a few skills that would come in handy in her new life. After a moment, she felt an unevenness under her fingers. *Are secret passages a hobby for sorcerers? Have they really turned this whole college into one big maze worse than Castle Crypto* she thought, feeling uneasy. She realized how different the truth about Mystacor must be from what Glimmer and Castaspella thought of it. *But not Mikah, the good old sorcerer sensed something was wrong with this place* She pressed down on the stone with all her strength until she was able to push it into his mum. The wall lifted up, revealing a corridor. It was short and narrow, but it seemed to widen at the end. It was bright enough here that she could see it clearly with her cat eyes…

A corpse lay at her feet. She had a strong stomach, so she didn't feel sick, but the smell was awful. He was a sorcerer, judging by his clothes, but she couldn't tell much more. Her face was blackened, and she saw worms in her mouth and eyes. She wasn't

sure what had killed him, but his spine and ribs had been shattered. It seemed to her that he was trying to get away from here, but he couldn't… She looked around worriedly. She was wagging her tail vigorously. She sensed that Melog was very nervous, but not only at the sight of the corpse. Something was going on there, something terrible...

"I think we'd better find Castaspella and show her what we found here... Before someone draws too far-reaching conclusions..." she said to herself slowly and went to look for the Head Sorcereress.

"Yes, of course, this also needs to be copied ... everything needs to be copied to computers ... I'm just not sure if in that order." she was explaining to a young librarian who was holding a book describing the lichens of the southern part of the northern reaches. The young foxperson looked at her with sad eyes, as if she had said that he would have to sell his beloved puppy. "Really, our… capacity is limited, we have to deal with the most important books first… It doesn't mean that this book isn't important, it's just not the most important, you understand?" she smiled at him, secretly hoping he would go away instead of staring at her

"What about *Vegetation of the northern slopes of the Storm Mountains in the southern Dryll*? This is probably the only copy of the only book describing the local vegetation." said the librarian with obvious desperation in his voice.

"Ugh... How about after *The History and Customs of the Moons Worshipers*? This book is lately constantly borrowed and now we have the opportunity to finally scan and copy it to meet the needs of everyone who uses the library." she said, hoping her ruse would work. But she had the uneasy feeling that she was going to have to give in to this botany battle anyway.

"Good Morning Lady Castaspello, may I help you with something?" she heard a voice nearby, sonorous but slightly hoarse. She

turned to see a tall woman wearing the light blue robes of a sorcerer. She was over six feet tall, almost as tall as Scorpia, though much slimmer. She had long, light blue hair pulled back in a bun, swarthy skin, and dark green eyes. Incredibly penetrating. She was into the weather or something... In fact, she hardly knew it... She had only recently come to Mystacor and had few friends. Her name was... Night Gale!

"Well ... Could you help me sort the documents and help with the bureaucracy a bit, it has grown a bit lately." she said smiling nervously. In fact, she was slowly losing her grip on what was going on at her own college. She wanted to ask Mikah for help, or Glimmer to delegate some clerks, but truth be told, she was ashamed. She didn't have much authority, not in Mystacor… And now she felt as though she was starting to much responsibilities. Plus the wedding and Victory Day celebrations… She wanted it to be an unforgettable day for all of them.

"Thank you very much for accepting my proposal." The woman bowed low. "But I'd like a day off on Victory Day." she said in a slightly apologetic tone.

"Of course, everyone has that day off." she said and added in her mind. *Apart from me, of course*

"You look tired, Lady Castaspello. Or do you need more help... I can help you with the wedding. I may not know much about throwing parties, but I can help with bills, shopping lists and stuff like that. I have a talent for numbers." she said with a friendly smile.

"Oh, you will help me with the wedding! It will be a wonderful event! Really! I was a little too young to help with Mikah's wedding, you know, my brother… It's wonderful that he was saved. Besides, it was a war then, and it wasn't appropriate to throw an overly lavish party. But now I'm going to do anything, absolutely anything, to make this the most wonderful day of Glimmer's life…and Bowa too! And She-Ra! That is Adora! And Catra, of course! They're getting married together... It doesn't

mean together, individually! This is… "she felt herself hyperventilating.

"I see, it must be wonderful to organize the wedding not only of your niece, but also of the Hero Reborn and Queen Etheri. It will be a great honor to help with such a historic event." she bowed low...

"That's good, but why do you want to help me." she said, feeling a sudden surge of distrust because of such a great desire to help her. Night Gale looked down.

"Well, I admit my motives are all too mundane, even materialistic. I hope that in the future you will show me your gratitude, Lady Castaspella, and allow me to be promoted."

"I understand..." *at least she's honest* " I'll think what can be done." she said and saw that Catra was standing behind Night Gale's back, she was clearly agitated. |Catra? Something happened?" she asked, seeing that Melog had taken on a slightly bluish color. Night Gale moved away from them but listened to their conversation.

"Let's say... You are very much needed right now."she said, looking around carefully.

"Are they having trouble copying books again? It's been happening all the time lately. The bureaucracy has grown on us somehow, I don't know how." she said embarrassed, because she herself had problems with embracing what was happening in Mystacor.

"No... Just come with me... It's… it's something very important..." Catra said. She understood that something had happened, and a very serious one.

"Okay, I'm on my way... Night Gale, would you please..."

" I'll go with you Lady Castaspella, my help may come in handy..." said the younger sorcerer. She shrugged and agreed...

Corpse lay in a hidden corridor. Not what she expected… Not in Mystacor. Not in her house.

"Do you know who it was? " Catra asked. She was pale, but didn't seem to want to regurgitate the last meal, unlike her. She walked over to the decomposing corpse and knelt down. She was green with disgust.

"It's a terrible sight…"Catra said sympathetically. She shook my head

"I've seen corpses and death before." she said quietly. "During that battle. It was the greatest clash in the history of Etheria. Powerful weapons and terrible spells were used back then... But this is Mystacor... a place that has always been safe, all these years of war... Do you understand? And now…" ahe closed her eyes. "It's been defiled."

Catra shrugged.

"I've never had a good association with that place... Whenever I'm here, I have the impression that I see falsehood... that everything around is just a mask hiding the true, terrible face. You know how I hate masks?"

She nodded thoughtfully.

"Yes, of course... No, I don't recognize him... I don't know all the sorcerers... In fact, I don't know most of them..." she sighed sadly.

"I know who he was!" Night Gale said. They turned to her, and Catra frowned as if only now realizing her presence.

"Who he was?" asked the Grand Marshal. There seemed to be suspicion in her voice.

"His name was Greycloud, and he was from the Moon Mountains surrounding Brightmoon Castle. I didn't know him very well, but apparently he went to the capital to visit his family and take part in the Victory Day celebrations."

"Well, I don't think he'll come to my wedding anymore..." Catra muttered extremely grimly and looked down the corridor. "What killed him came from there." she added.

She looked down the corridor and felt… something. As if she felt that something was waiting for her there… Something beautiful and wonderful. Without realizing it, she took two steps over the corpse.

"Castaspella... Shouldn't we call the guards or something?" Catra asked cautiously, looking at her uncertainly. She obviously didn't feel what she felt...
"Interesting ... Have you looked at this corpse? Looks like someone drained this Greycloud of blood… " Night Gale said with obvious interest as she knelt by the corpse. Catra looked at her over her shoulder.

"If they fascinate you so much, you can even cut them up, I don't forbid... I feel like I'm talking to the child of Entrapta and Shadow Weaver." the Grand Marshal replied quietly. There was a soft snort behind her, but she ignored it. She bent down and began to squeeze through the narrow corridor.

"Castaspella, what are you doing? Are you sure you want to go to the place where the thing that killed that sorcerer is sitting?" Catra asked her, but she didn't listen... She had to keep going towards what was calling her. It was something beautiful and wonderful.

She didn't like how Castaspella was starting to act, just as she didn't like Night Gale's presence. There was something about the strange blue-haired sorcereress that repulsed her. It was hard to describe. At first she thought it was because of her height, but

she was used to being around Scorpia, the Clones who had taken up residence in Brightmoon, and finally She-Ra. For a moment, she thought she smelled an indefinable scent from that woman, familiar and alien at the same time. Then everything was covered with the stench of rotting corpses that made Castaspella nearly vomit, though Night Gale didn't seem to be much impressed. She had a vague feeling that the woman was unimpressed by anything. She stepped over the corpse, being careful not to soil Castaspelli's socks, though she feared that the Head Sorcereress paid no attention to her robes and had probably let them get dirty. Night Gale followed, of course, how else with her luck.

The corridor widened slowly until they found themselves in a huge hall with several columns. She felt shivers run down her spine. *Not the cursed ruins of the First Ones again... I hate everything that has anything to do with them... Almost everything...*. She smiled to herself and looked around. Everywhere were tall stone columns covered with strange writings in a language she did not know, but which was clearly not the language of the First Ones. She wasn't sure if that was a good sign, there was something unsettling here, some overwhelming darkness that seemed to crush her with its weight. Sometimes, once or twice, she'd felt something similar when she walked into Shadow Weaver's workshop after performing some dark ritual. She remembered once finding her lying as if lifeless, the smell of burning and ozone everywhere. She pulled her out of the lab and called the medics. The dark sorcerer even thanked her…then threatened that she would face dire consequences if she entered her workshop without permission again. *Yes, this place has a Shadow Weaver feel to it* she thought. Castaspella summoned the light and the whole room appeared to them in all its glory. It was made entirely of basalt blocks, in the shape of a cube. Attached to the pillars were holders for luminous stones that were now long extinguished. She'd seen the murals on the walls, but they weren't in that spooky style that imitated the art of the First Ones. They were simpler, even conventional, as if those creating them did not care about at least a minimal representation of reality, but only to show the general sense of events. At the far end of the room was

a statue made of a single block of stone. It depicted a tall man with a face devoid of details, consisting mainly of sharp edges, whose right side was snow-white and the left black as the darkest abys. But what she was most interested in was another corpse. There were four bodies, two were common folk of Etheria, armed with the well-known electric battle batons, and the other two were sorcerers, one lying among the other corpses, and the last propped on a pedestal, his hand reaching for some jewel. It was like deep blue amber, half transparent, and something seemed to sparkle inside… Something alive…

"Castaspella, something here is wrong."The hair on her tail stood up. She extended her claws ready to attack. Melog clung to the ground, waiting for her command. However, the Head Sorcereress seemed to pay no attention to her. She was in a trance, slowly walking towards the strange gem

"It possessed her... Very interesting." said Night Gale in a voice as if commenting on the behavior of a silly animal.

"I can see, instead of standing and looking, help me maybe stop her! - she snapped at the tall sorcereress. But she hesitated herself. She could easily overpower Castaspella, but she didn't want to be brutal with Glimmer’s Auntie, and that moment of hesitation was enough for the sorcereress to put her hand on the stone. At the last moment, she tried to grab her arm, but the Head Sorcerer used a fiery spark on her arm, she felt a strong pain, so she let go of Castaspella. The sorcereress shot her an angry look.

"Why are you interrupting?! It would be better for everyone if Shadow Weaver never found you!" she said in a venomous tone.

It hurt more than a fier spell. No one has spoken to her that way in five years. It opened wounds she thought had already healed. She pursed her lips, ready to stun the Head Sorceress this time without remorse. But then Castaspelli's eyes and mouth flashed with a blue light. This meant something very bad. She wanted to stop her anyway, but then out of the corner of her eye she saw

that it wasn't the sorcerer's corpse closest to the landing that had moved. She felt herself dying of horror. *This can't be... These things don't happen,* she thought, disbelieving what she was seeing. The corpse got up, most of its wounds healed. He was tall and pale.

- Don't disturb her if the Watcher’s Eye wants to show her something. Please don't move and let me feed. - He smiled, revealing two rows of sharp fangs.
She heard Night Gale say the words of the incantation.

She looked around. She was in the Whispering Woods, in one of its deepest parts. She frowned. She was ashamed to admit it, but she didn't like the forest that Brightmoon owed its survival to. She had spent most of her life in Mystacor and a few surrounding towns, and she was comfortable there. She liked the company of others, meeting them for afternoon tea, going to parties, teaching young people ... And the wildness of the Whispering Woods, its unbridled primal power and the overwhelming feeling that everything was pervaded by some primal presence, as if the whole forest had a consciousness of its own, frightened her. She could feel it even now, but it was something else, as if there had been a change in the forest… A terrible change

She saw trees around her. They were strangely twisted, no trunk or branch growing straight, as if they had been bent by some terrible disease. The leaves were red, purple or even black. They all had strange, asymmetrical shapes, often covered with bristles. White bony thorns often pierced the bark of the trees, and blood-red resin oozed from the cracks. She saw black butterflies perching to drink her. She shivered. Whispers, usually on the verge of being heard, were louder now, she felt as if they resounded with despair and suffering. "Where i found myse? What happened to the Whispering Woods? What happened to Etheria?" she asked herself. She had no idea how she would find her way to... anywhere... Once, when she was sixteen, Mikah took her into the woods for two weeks, and after she got lost for the sixteenth

time, he decided a week is long enough. *Casta, just keep going and it'll be okay, just keep going!* she commanded herself.

Fortunately, she soon came to a path that she recognized quite well, mainly because she had spent some of the most important days of her life here, when the fate of Etheria, and perhaps the entire Galaxy, hung in the balance. She was right outside the Horde's hidden supply base, where the remnants of the rebellion were hiding. Here he will surely find some answers to what is going on here. She crossed the high entrance to the cave.

Adora was on guard in the form of She-Ra, which was probably good, because she would answer all her questions, she would finally know what was going on ... But why was she here, all tense and wielding a sword. She was sitting cross-legged, her side turned to her. She was smiling from the corner of her mouth, grimly and somewhat sarcastically.

"Come here instead of sneaking around!" Adora called, and she did as she was told, but Glimmer came out of the depths of the room. She had obviously grown her hair long since they'd last met, and she wore armor, though she remembered rarely wearing it since the end of the war.

"You've always had good hearing." her niece said, and Adora stood up, and she drew in a sharp breath, when she looked at her. The heroine of Etheria had a long scar on her cheek, and her right eye was blind. Glimmer walked over to her and touched her mutilated face very… tenderly?

"You know, ever since we found you in the woods, injured and lost... Since then, I knew... I knew we'd be together forever...

I think you censored the story of how you met a bit.... she thought unconsciously. What happened to Adora? Why had no one told her… not even… Catra…

"Oh Sparkle." Adora said softly with a clearly mocking smile and kissed Queen of Etheria...

"NOOOOO." she exclaimed not believing her eyes. This couldn't be happening. "Glimmer, Adora! And the wedding! You are to get married! I mean, not you! But you! Ugh… Why is it so complicated! You didn't think how Bow would feel! And... Catra! Especially Catra!" She felt the ground shift from under her feet. *What am I going to tell Catra... She's... She's in the library... I'm in..*

"Oh... how romantic. Entrapta called from the depths of the room, watching the whole scene with delight

Glimmer groaned and teleported away from Adora, who crossed her arms over her chest, looking at her triumphantly. The queen turned beet red in the face.

"But anyway, we don't have time. I just received a transmission from that ship we contacted and… we're already five minutes late." she exclaimed, speaking quickly and energetically.

"So we're leaving Etheria... " said her niece. Tears ran down her cheeks. "What is going on here? Did someone attack us? When things got so bad?" she thought, then saw Bow.

"Honey, I copied what we managed to salvage from Darla's memory." he turned to Entrapta and kissed her cheek.

"Poor Darla." said the Lady of Dryll.

At least I won't have to explain anything to him... Only Hordek needs someone to explain it... but let him get stuffed... she thought, but then she saw that everyone was coming to Glimmer to transfer them, so she quickly ran to her and touched her niece's arm...

Her hand passed through Glimmer's body... *I became a ghost.... No, ghosts don't exist… It's a vision* she thought, realizing with sudden clarity that she was in a library. In this strange chamber full of corpses, along with Catra and Night Gale…. She suddenly felt a rush of self-delight. "It's wonderful ... Some power has

decided ... " she thought, but then Glimmer and the others disappeared. She wandered helplessly.

"What is it supposed to be. For visions to be visions, someone must see them ... „ she said ... to the universe. She closed her eyes. *Maybe if I think hard about where I want to be, that's where I'll be?* thought she wanted you with Glimmer now. She felt her head spinning. And she opened her eyes. Her method worked, but she didn't like what she saw. They were in the Brightmoon mountains. Castle... He has changed. The walls were blackened like teeth turned by decay. It was entwined with a strange black vine that looked more like intestines than a plant.

Look how beautiful, not like Darla, but still cute. Will they let me look at it closely? Look, I think they has." Entrapta pointed to a large black ship hovering above them. It was slender, but it looked predatory, no less predatory than the ships of the Galactic Horde. He seemed to blur the space around him. A smaller ship left it and headed for the escarpment where they were arriving. As it flew in, the side door opened and Catra stepped in. But she looked different. She had pageboy hair cut and wore dark purple armor. She had no right arm, only a strange prosthesis, as if made of a single piece of unfamiliar metal. She was different, seemed extremely serious, and exuded the discipline of a soldier…

"I'm First Officer Fenyx. We've got five minutes, then we'll be tracked…and welcome aboard Merciless." she said in a firm tone.

"Oh, not so fast ... Our beautiful heroine and her charming queen ... They probably shouldn't just leave the inhabitants of this wonderful planet ... Abandon them to evil and darkness." The voice was gentle and dignified, with a beautiful sound, but there was something ominous about it. It seemed to come from everywhere, She-Ra-Adora turned pale... Something moved in the shadows, and then she felt a terrible pain...

It was Melog who saved her. The Not-Dead creature was already reaching out to slit her throat with its claws. But the creature from Kryat sent her emotions. Fear…anger…and rage… She knew it all too well, but now it was the emotion she needed. She regained control of her body and dodged to the side, then slammed her claws into the creature's shoulder, slicing through the tendons to the bone. Then Night Gale cast a spell that drove the Not-Dead away from her.

"What's that supposed to be? Shadow Weaver told us fairy tales about such monsters, but she did not believe in their existence!"

"Then tell him that." The sorcereress said in a calm voice, as if nothing out of the ordinary was happening.

The creature slowly began to rise, oblivious to the flesh torn to the bone, and the deep gash gaping in its chest.

"You only make my task more difficult for me... Turn around and don't come again.- the creature hissed. He was wearing sorcerer's robes, though of an unfamiliar style. what was he? She remembered a story Shadow Weaver had once told them...

"Release Castaspella... Free our companion." she ordered the creature, while allowing Melog to disappear

…
"I don't hold her... It's the Watcher's Eye that holds her mind and will only release it when it sees fit... If it ever does, and even then there's no guarantee she will come back as she was before. The Watcher has gone through a lot at the hands of the Eternals..." said the being without taking his eyes off her. It looked like a human, with a long, thin beard, but she couldn't tell for sure. The face was haggard and deathly pale with visible bones, as if someone had pulled a previously peeled and dried face back over the skull. *And the Princess of the Night was not dead, for her hunger was stronger than death.*

"He won't let us go, he can't, because then this secret will come out. A secret is only safe when everyone who knows it is dead."Night Gale said grimly. The Not-Dead smiled, showing sharp fangs, and lunged at them with unexpected speed. Then the sorcerer bound the creature's legs with magical bonds, and Melog jumped on its back as the creature fell to the ground. The Not-Dead tried to grab the last of the inhabitants of Kryat, but she grabbed one of his arms and twisted him. But the being who don’t know pain cared little, continuing to resist until she heard the sound of bones breaking. But then the creature jerked free, knocking Melog off his back and leaving a severed arm in her hands, which immediately began to crumble to dust. *What else was there? And the brave warrior drove a stake into the wicked breast, putting an end to tyranny... Where am I supposed to find a stake here?* she looked around and saw one of the Horde's old electric batons. She knew how to use them. The Not-Dead stood over her and grinned as he reached for her with his only hand, though the one he had lost had begun to grow back. The sorcereress entwined the creature again, but this time magical bonds wrapped around its neck, and Melog sank its teeth into its calf. Then she got up and jumped, shoved him hard in the chest. The weapon came out the other way, shattering the sternum and spine. The creature stared at her in amazement for a moment, then smiled and began to crumble to dust. She stood up panting heavily, Melog rubbing against her legs.

"Interesting idea... to pierce his heart... How did you come up with that?" Night Gale asked curiously.

"Reminds me of a fairy tale about killing evil princesses." she murmured and looked at Castaspella - Louse how to wake her up? Night Gale shook her head.

She looked at the electric baton and thought for a moment, then set the baton to low power and placed it against the Chief Warlock's back. *You'll thank me later.* And she pressed the button.

When she regained consciousness, the first thing she felt was a terrible pain in her back. When she opened her eyes, she saw Catra above her with her hands behind her back.

"Are you… well…"Adora's fiancée asked in a strangely innocent voice.

She stood up rubbing her back and nodded her head.

"I'm fine, but my back hurts." she said, frowning and trying to remember something… something very important.

"And your name is..." er voice was even more innocent and she took two steps towards her... Very strange for Catra.

"Well, I'm Castaspella, did you forgot? ..."she said, and then suddenly all the memories came back. She grabbed the Grand Marshal by the shoulders

"Oh Catra, I had visions, terrible visions…"she said and shook her. The Grand Marshal stiffened all over.

"That's very interesting, but could you let go of me and step back half a meter?" she said slowly, clearly, barely keeping her nerves under control.

"Oh, sorry, I forgot…" she released her and stepped back. And then she started talking about everything she saw.

"I was in the Whispering Woods but it was changed and scary and we were back in that hideout with Adora and Glimmer and they kiiii…hugging." she said, realizing she had almost said something that could have unforeseen consequences...

"They hug a lot and it's quite normal for them? " Catra asked with a hint of suspicion.

"Yes, that's quite typical of them, of course, and there's nothing unusual about it." She took a deep breath. "And you were there, but on a spaceship outside of Etheria, and I don't think anyone

recognized you… And what exactly happened here? " she asked, looking around.

"I just had to remember one of the spooky stories the Shadow Weaver used to tell us." Catra said. She looked strangely pale and worried, as if what she'd just heard had upset the Grand Marshal, and she seemed about to say something, something very important, but she looked at Night Gale, who was kneeling by the corpse, and instea she said.

"I'm going to have to take tetanus shots... I hate shots... And thanks Night Gale for your help!"

"You're welcome... "said the sorcereress, and Catra looked at her surprised.

Night Gale stood over the corpse, pride welling up in her heart. Not only did she manage to gain Castaspelli's trust, but she also unraveled the mystery of a group of traitors... "See? Curiosity doesn't pay" she thought, tearing off the amulet depicting a skull with spikes stuck in its eye sockets. "You see! I'm not a Failure!"
***
This is probably the longest chapter. I won't post another one this week because I'm going on vacation until the end of the week.

Loneliness

Rosie looked around at her companions. The weird feline and her friends conferred silently, Dilayla glumly watching the alien, who in turn was talking quietly to the strange bot. She… felt strangely lonely. She had actually always been lonely, but now she felt it so much. She had no family, friends, or even a name. She was named because of the symbol of the capsule she was found in and the color of her hair. She didn't know where she was from and she had no idea where she was going. She was like a leaf blown by the wind. She had never made friends with anyone, nor had she thought of anything more. Her lack of hearing also separates her from the rest of society. She always watched others, feeling like she was in a glass ball herself, unable to become part of their world. So it was now. She felt that despite the heat, she was getting cold, cold inside. It was as if she were alone on an endless plain, the only creature under the open sky, yet unnoticed by anyone. "Was it like this before? Was I alone in my past life too? Or am I the last representative of my kind? And my people no longer exis?t." She thought and felt tears well up in her eyes. She had to do something not to cry in front of everyone. She decided to approach a bunch of friends, they were discussing something fiercely. She knelt some distance away, but her glasses projected everything they said.

"I don't care what Bina says, she can't order us. We had a good reason to go to town and look what we found out." said Itel, gesticulating fiercely.

"All we know is that our old friend from Kesler is nearby and is interested in Wrogdak, though only the gods can understand why." said Alatar, scratching the back of his neck.

"I agree with the drakey here. It's just a dull and stupid clone, nothing worth even a broken coin." Eti said sharply. The others looked at her meaningfully, as if he had said something very… inappropriate. "Come on? Only his bot is dumber than him." added the strange Pahtra after a moment.

"But the half-elf said otherwise... His... race attacked her planet or something. He himself claims that he belonged to some completely-not-orcish-horde." Itel said, but Lilka interrupted him.

"Absolutely is not an orc, but she can fight like orc." said the red-haired girl, thinking for a moment

"Really? With beings that can move and see anything?" Eti asked with clear skepticism.

"Really... You didn't see him smash that bot." Dragonkin said, and Lilka nodded her head. Suddenly the elf stood up and turned sharply towards Rosie

"Don't eavedrop us!" she glared at the intern, who jumped back in fright.

"Don't peek us." Eti interjected.

"What?" The green-haired elf looked at the shooter, not really understanding what she was talking about. Eti sighed heavily and began to explain.

"She's deaf, so by definition she can't eavesdrop."she shook her head.

"The Devil's Advocate has arrived." The elf exclaimed angrily.

"Not a devil's advocate, but a person who makes sure that others use the language correctly." Replied the strange Pahtra. Rosie looked at the other two.

Dragonkin held up a datapad that read *Don't interrupt them or they'll both bite you.*

"She almost broke your nose!"The elf shouted back, waving her hands strongly.

"Yeah, that's what happens when people fight." Eti was saying, but Rosie cut in and pulled away.

"Maybe I'll go now, I don't want you two to quarrel." she squared her hands conciliatoryly and walked away from them. She looked around and saw that the alien… Wrongdak was talking to this bot. So she went to them.

"Hello! I'm Rosie Pearl! Nice to meet you!" she said with a friendly smile. The stranger stood up and bowed to her.

"Hi! I am Wrongdak. Actually Wrong Hordak." he smiled at her and pointed at the Droid. "And this is Emily."

"Hi Emily. Hi Wrongdak!" she waved at them and sat down. "Why are you called Wrong Hordak? It's all right with you." she tilted her head wanting to get better look at him, but she didn't see anything strange, except that he did look a bit like he wanted to look like Skittermander. But she had no idea what members of his species were supposed to look like.

"My friend, an extremely wise woman, freed me! She thought I was my brother then... Her friend and lab assistant. She gave me freedom... I know I got that name by mistake, but I like it." he said, moving closer to Emily.

"And Emily? Where did her name come from? Did you named her that?" she asked, kneeling beside Emily.

"No... My friend did that too. She woke her up, made her wiser. But it was my brother who built her."

She furrowed her brow, thinking for a moment.

"If your brother built her and your friend woke her up, that means they made her together... So she's kind of their baby and you're her uncle." she said and puffed her breast proudly.

Wrongdak looked at her surprised.

"Yes, you are right! I never thought of it that way." he stroked the bot on the lid, and Rosie did the same.

"Are you with them? Are you a member of their group?" she asked, looking at the strange four young people, who were now arguing fiercely, but according to the Elf's wish, she did not eavesdrop on them ... Or rather, she did not peek them, as Eti put it.

Wrongdak shook his head

"No, but they freed me and Emily... Grag... He wanted to sell me. Like a thing!" The white-skinned alien clenched his fists and now looked really menacing.

"It's terrible... Such things don't happen here on Absalom."she said, genuinely indignant.

He looked at her in admiration.

"Are you from Absalom? It's supposedly an amazing place. My friends would probably like it… Maybe we'll all go there someday."

"Enough of this little talk, don't bother her!" Dilayla stepped behind her and lifted her shoulders.

"I didn't bother her. We were just talking." Wrongdak defended himself. Dilala was tall in power armor, but the alien could look her straight in the eye anyway.

"Yeah, I remember when on Minitar thirty years ago your people spoke terribly politely to us too." she looked at Wrongdak menacingly, and he lowered his gaze.

"I… I'm really sorry about my brothers. We… we really had no choice…" he didn't finish as Dilayla interrupted him.

"That's what all soldiers say when they justify their crimes."

"I... I've never actually been a soldier... I'm just over six years old." Wrongdak said smiling sadly. Dilayla looked at him confused

"So…" she asked carefully.

"He's a clone..." she looked at the mercenary resentfully.

"I see." she said, looking at the stranger carefully, as if to evaluate him.

" I knew ... I knew young soldiers whose life or cruel politicians forced them to fight at war." she glanced at the four, who had apparently already agreed on something by this point, because Itel got up and started walking towards them. :But I'll keep an eye on you anyway!" the mercenary threatened.

"Listen, we'll go to the observatory together. And then we'll have dinner... or supper, because we have a proposition for you."

"And transportation?" Dilayla asked skeptically. "It's quite far from here."

"You will ride the greatest armored personnel carrier in the galaxy!" Eti shouted.

"Which is pretty crazy." Alatar added.

Bina sighed.

"Ireanis, if you stick your blunt head through the hatch, something will tear it off." she asked the Elven sorceress, who was looking out the top hatch.

"It's proposition?" A hoarse voice came from the speakers.

"No, Crushey. We don't murder crew members." Bina said dispassionately.

"So those who are not crew members, I can? BUHAHAHA" Crushey chuckled loudly.

"Don't start this discussion again.." she threatened the transporter. Meanwhile, Ireanis came downstairs.

"Don't worry, I just went out to get some air.If I saw a tree, I would immediately hide." she said, smiling conciliatory.

"We are in the desert, there are not many trees here." Bina said to the silver-haired woman.

"Ah... that explains a lot." Ireanis sat awkwardly in the seat and buckled her seat belt crookedly.

Bina sighed. Sometimes she felt so lonely... *I never asked to be mother of four kids... Especially kids that were so wronged and weird.* She watched Ireanis play with the switch. *The five most twisted kids in the known worlds. Alone… With a little help from a couple of absolutely untrustworthy individuals*. she wanted to laugh through her tears. *And most of these kids...all except Eti are older than me...Isn't this world a goddamn joke.* She watched the surroundings through the monitor screen, although the vehicle also had a normal viewfinder and even an optical periscope, in case someone used an EMP weapon or a nuclear bomb ... " It's not airtight enough to keep the crew from dying from radiation." She smiled crookedly. Kessler's army purchased plenty of these vehicles, they were hugely popular across the galaxy, but only the Crusher had AI. Simple and not entirely self-aware ... but he was as crazy as the rest of her charges.

"I don't like these little cars. They laugh at me." Crushey said with anger in his voice.

"They're not laughing at anyone. They don't have computers... and probably no electrical parts, so they can't laugh at you, or probably anyone at all." she explained like a wayward child. "Yeah, this is my sixth child and I'm only ten chronologically. They should give me some sort of reward"

"Can I run them over?" Crusher asked her pleadingly.

She sighed.

"No, you can not." She replied in an emotionless voice. She had had this conversation many times before and she didn't care. Her life was essentially about keeping their crew from harming themselves and others.

"When we get back to the ship, you'll review our purchases." she said to Ireanis The elf nodded, and Bina could only hope she was listening instead of thinking on important matters such as the latest season of "Love under the stars and the moon" or what horse thats give a power were fed on. The captain looked over her shoulder and smiled contentedly. She bought everything they needed and told them to pack the most interesting things on Crushey, mainly good food, especially meat for Eti and sweets for Lilka and Alatar, and even a set of knives for filleting meat for Itel and Eti, although she wasn't sure if it was the best idea. They both liked playing with sharp objects far too much… The supplies would be delivered to the ship, that grumpy duergar had said. The fact was that she could understand him. He recently injured his leg and had to use a crutch to get around. Even in such a calm industry as running a warehouse, extremely tragic accidents can happen. But at least he had sanitary napkins and toilet paper, though when he heard she was taking six months' supply right away, Duergar looked at her as if wondering if she was trying to compete with him. *I've always been bothered by all those travelers who ignore hygiene issues because it's a waste of a few credits she shook her head, grimacing in disgust.* Well, she was proud of how hygienic she was, though she suspected it was some kind of weirdness Jantar had instilled in her. *But that's what I'm grateful for.* She thought and scratched her forearm where she had a tattoo with a serial number on it. She always scratched him when she thought of Father. *You gave us a lot, but you took even more from us.* she thought. Even though she was in a better situation than Eti. After all, it wasn't so... refined. . And she pulled out the steering wheel taking control of the machine.. "I wasn't made for this.. for all this. I was supposed to be a swindler, a swordsman of the word... and I ended up adoptive mother, ship captain, and goddamn treasure hunter. What's wrong with me?" she thought. She drove for a few minutes, Crusher was silent,

obviously resentful of her for taking control. She wanted return to the ship, wondering what she would find when she returned.

Then the communicator woke up.

"Hi Bina…I must tell you something." she heard Alatar's voice. she sighed. They always had Alator talk to her when they messed something up…

"What's on fire?" she asked straight.

"We didn't burn anything... Why would we set fire to anything?" he asked with almost believable innocence.

"Dragonkin, solarian, grenadier with incendiary grenades, "Orc" with flaming axe. You are setting fires with your mere presence." she replied.

"But we didn't set anything on fire. You know, could you give us and some friends a ride somewhere?" he asked very politely.

"So you're not on the ship? Be honest, did you plan this from the beginning? You didn't care about my orders ... my REQUEST and you went around the city not knowing what to do, right? Do you even respect me at all and take my opinion into account?!" she screamed at them and struggled to control the vehicle.

"I'm sorry…" the technomancer said in a hushed voice.

"Okay, tell me, my dear ... Did you hurt anyone?" she asked, though she already knew the answer.

"Do I have to answer this question?" he replied in a pleading tone, but then Eti interjected.

"Toad... Bina, aren't you demanding too much from us? Don't you think what impact such pressure can have on the development of our adolescent minds? We feel overwhelmed by the incredible weight you put on our shoulders!"

"Eti, I'm just asking you not to behave like a bunch of thugs!" she screamed, then stopped the car and counted to ten.

"All right, just put your coordinates on the datapad and I'll come get you." she said, regaining her self-control. *The essence of my existence*

Eti has always been lonely. It wasn't just who…what she was. It was her mind. More than two thousand days ago, her soul was shattered and then brutally reforged. Brutal, but unskilful. Bina thought she understood, but her mind was barely touched. She had only knowledge, pure and devoid of context. Eti had so much more. Her psyche... the whole emotional world was trying to be chained in the shackles... of the future she had chosen... in the shackles of her cursed heritage. Bina had certain predispositions, but Eti was never sure whether what she felt, what she did belonged to her or was forced into her mind. She had only met Jantar once or twice, but she hated him more than Bina has, who had taken his life. Though of course, he wasn't the first one she wanted to resurrect, and then to kill again... That honor belonged to someone else...

She got up when she heard an armored personnel carrier approaching in the distance. Thanks to her hearing, she was always the first to know when Crushey was approaching. She could tell it apart from other vehicles, even vehicles like him. Her friends knew her well enough to join her. Wormdak did it too, though he probably didn't understand why, but his empty cloned head was capable of primitive imitation. Sparkle Fingers and Fist weren't sure what was going on, so they stood confused.

They had moved away from the battlefield and were now in the spacious driveway of an unfinished single-family home. There was a large yellow grass with deep roots and sharp leaves, which, when crushed, rose up after a while. She knew such plants from Akiton and knew that it could grow almost anywhere. She missed Akiton. Crushey came roaring loudly. He was beautiful. It had an

attached dozer and spikes. They painted him eyes, dragon's teeth and flames. It was probably the most beautiful vehicle in the entire galaxy. She saw Sparkle Fingers staring at Crushey with her mouth open, and Fist whistled.

"We rode something like this during the Siram battles and a couple of other campaigns. I think we on Minitar even used them. Old, but good. Where did you get it from?" asked the half-elf.

"We used it to escape the swarm on Kesler... It's a Long Story... his name is Crusher, but we call him Crushey.

Fist looked at the technomancer with a mixture of disbelief and admiration.

Crushey stood beside them and the side door opened. Inside was Ireanis, who was trying to get up and wave at them without unbuckling her seatbelt.

Operating the passenger seat, even after those five years, was beyond her skill. Bina stood in the doorway and smiled cheekily.

"I see that my band of thugs are wandering around the city looking for a tumor… " she commented on seeing them, then turned to their companions.

"Hello! I'm Bina, and there in the armchair grins Ireanis. I'm sorry if my wards might have scared you a bit…" She said almost apologetically.

"Your wards saved me from a terrible fate..." said Wormdak, and then Eti interrupted him.

"This is Wormdak and Dumbbot sits next to him, the white-haired one is Sparkle Fingers, and the big one is Fist." she said quickly the real names of the new companions. The four of them, along with Dumbbot, looked at her.

"You have just become acquainted with the wonderful and remarkably uniting practice of our Eti of calling other by

nicknaming others." Bina sighed heavily. The scout frowned at this simplistic explanation of what she was doing.

"I don't nickname, I just give others names that reflect their character, appearance, and personality much better than the ones their parents gave them at birth." she said proudly.

"But I wasn't given a name at birth... Nor was Emily... We weren't born at all... I guess." said Wormdak and thought for a moment, and Bina looked at him in surprise, but said nothing.

"I... don't know my birth name either, but now I'm Rosie Pearl, and this is Wrongdak and Emily." Sparkle Fingers pointed to the alien and the bot. - And there is Dilayla, my traveling companion and friend.

Bina smiled warmly at the deaf-mute girl" And I'm Bina, and that one is ..." she didn't finish, because finally the elven Mystic freed herself from her belts and stood in the doorway, almost throwing her captain out of the vehicle.

"I'm Ireanis..." she did one pirouette -...Toromech..." she made another pirouette "... called the Silver Flame." she turned one last time, and silver sparks flew from her hands. She jumped back as soon as she realized that the elven mage was about to do magic, and so did her friends, but the rest of them didn't realize what could happen when Ireanis began to do magic. The spell seemed to work this time... almost... Sparkle Fingers saw sparks sparkle on her clothes, she began to extinguish them in horror, then began to extinguish Wormdak, who was watching Ireanis in awe.

"The lady is a great sorceress! I was also friends with a great sorceress. She made me a sweater… But I think I lost it when I was imprisoned." he smirked at those words.

"You didn't lose it. Oh here it is." Lilka took off her backpack and searched through it until she found a sweater. Wool and warm. Three faces are embroidered on it. I think one of them belonged to Wormdak, only then he had a completely different hair color.

Next to it was another similar alien, only with red eyes and blue hair, and next to it was a smiling woman with purple hair. She suspected it was his brother and friend.

"That's was in the warehouse with lots of different items in such a box ... when we were leaving, I scooped them up so that they wouldn't be wasted." Lilka said smiling proudly. Bina hid her face in her hands.

"Please, tell me you didn't assault anyone to rob him." she said resignedly...

"Well, in a way. There was only one Duergar." Alatar tried to explain himself. "Toady"
Bina groaned

"This is the guy I used to buy sanitary pads and toilet paper from. By demons and devils, what's you where thinking?"

Then Wormdak stepped forward. He bowed low to everyone and said.

"Please don't be angry with them. They saved me... This Grag... he wanted to sell me... into slavery like a thing and he sold Emily. Itel, Eti, Lilka, Alatar ... They are heroes ..." he said with Exaltation, and Eti felt a shiver run down her spine. *I'm not a hero. I do not want to be. I'm me! No one will take that away from me.*

She scowled at Wormdak. Bina, however, seemed to be impressed. Nothing unusual.

"If it's true... And I believe him... Well, you could tell he was a filthy brute, this Grag. I could have let Crushey run him over." she said in a softer tone

"You could. - The hoarse voice of the vehicle came from inside. Wormdak watched their transporter with fascination.

"I'm Dilayla, and we are … never mind. Anyway, there was discussion between us here ... so I decided to help them ..." Fist said in a consistent tone.

" What do you need help with?" Bina asked with a hint of suspicion.

Itel approached her hard clenching her fists.

"It's the observatory! I told you he's out there somewhere! And we found its location now we have to go there…"

"All right, let's go." Bina interrupted her.

"What?" asked the elf in surprise.

"What I said. We drive. Since you've already gone out to the city, we might as well go there" Bina said and turned to Sparcle fingers and Fist.

"Then get aboard the craziest transporter in the galaxy!" she exclaimed, and laughed a little nervously, which was her habit lately. *Why you are mean to Crushey?*

I have condemned myself to loneliness. For everyone to fear me and hate me at the same time. And I was so proud of myself. she thought as she got out of the car. The driver stopped at a combination of a store and a gas station, then told them he wasn't going anywhere else. Arkan-tar tried to persuade him to take them further, but Shiren swore that doing so would only destroy his landing gear. She considered whether she should use her powers to force his obedience, but changed her mind. She didn't want to give away her power just yet, and besides, it was only an hour and two away on foot. they had time.
"Dear Arkan, just ask him to wait for us until the evening ... and buy water!" she said to the scholar. An hour later, she regretted that decision.

She wasn’t used to the sun. Carurystal was almost always cloudy, so she didn't experience its glow on a daily basis. It was still something completely new and unfamiliar to her. Its rays made her tired quickly. Her eyes were squinted and she couldn't see much, and she was panting in the heat. She didn't sweat like other humanoid mammals, and she wondered if she was at risk of heatstroke. *I wonder what they think about the sun, are they delighted with it? Adora probably did, so did Glimmer, they always liked the light of day ... And Catra? Thanks to me, she learned to hide in the dark. I showed her the power of darkness, both that outside and inside. I hope she never goes my way again and that she is basking in the sun like a cat… cuddled up to Adora.* She thought, and immediately felt pain and self-loathing, for she was about to return to Etheria and disturb their hard-won peace.

Slowly, she considered casting a spell that would make her body shrouded in shadows. They both already knew part of the truth about her, so such a manifestation of power would not surprise anyone. *The truth about me... indeed few knew it.* she thought. If on Etheria hatred separated her from other, here it was the Truth. She wasn't afraid of being discovered. On Carurystal, only two people knew the all truth about who Miss Daisy really was. *What would you well-bred people of respectable families do if you found out you were having afternoon tea with a war criminal? The most hated person on her’s planet? Who betrayed everyone and everything? Though, as Lady Cala said, most wouldn't even believe it, and some would probably justify me… Defend me!* She laughed nervously, and Arkan-tar and Rechiza looked at her confused.

" thought of tea with my neighbors on Carurystal, and i imagined a very funny joke." she said smiling crookedly. *Plus, it dries me out, damn.* Her companions exchanged worried glances. Now they think I'm an old madwoman, she thought, and started to prepare to cast a spell that would shroud her in shadow, but then she heard a vehicle approaching. She turned and saw an armored personnel carrier, albeit oddly decorated with painted eyes, teeth, and spikes attached. Hordak strictly forbade decorating Horde-

produced vehicles, only years later did she understand why, so such a sight was a bit surprising to her.

"Who could it be? In a place like this, the sight of a military vehicle, even one, raises anxiety." Rechiza said clearly ready to fight.

"For me, it's someone who can give us a lift." Arkan-tar replied in a slightly cheerful tone, though he moved his hands towards the weapon. She herself was ready to fight, although she doubted that even in such a place, attacks on random travelers did happen on a daily basis. And even if it did, well, they won't have easy prey. The transporter stood by them, and the side door opened. A burgundy-haired woman named Bina stood there and smiled happily.

"What a small planet! I didn't have time to tell you, but I got us an archaeologist to help with your mission. You see Itel, you're not the only one who cares about this mission. "she said, and a beaming Rosie stood next to her.

"Oh, Miss Daisy, Arkan and Rechiza. They are friends of me and Dilayla. Why are you looking so strange?" the intern asked in sign language.

She didn't know why Arkan-tar looked puzzled, but she had a clear reason. She saw a Droid, one of those Hordak mass-produced. But this one was special, she remembered how she had devastated her garden in Brightmoon. *If she's here, Entrapta or Scorpia must be here. Princess of Dryl didn't seem to care much about living creatures, but Scorpia, while not the brightest, had been around me for quite long time to get to know me, and by the end of the war both sides had learned how dangerous Scorpia can be* This could greatly complicate Cala's plans, as well as Creeping Chaos itself. Am I ready for this? Will I ever be?" she asked herself in her mind.

However, the person who stood by Rosie's side made her heart stop. Hordak… Hordak here. Her superior, the one whose will she

had carried out for thirty years. *Have they decided to send you to a truly provincial planet to spend the rest of your days forgotten and meaningless? I wouldn't have suspected Glimmer of having such a wonderful... sense of justice.*

But then she looked at the stranger. He had colorful hair, a wool sweater, and a friendly smile. *It's the other one that Entrapta took in like a puppy... How he was named... it doesn't matter. Miss Daisy never met him anyway.* She saw the consternation beginning to appear on the faces of the others, and she smiled.

"I see Rosie, you've found friends! Making conections with people you meet is a very important skill among young people." she said in a friendly tone. She was practically honest. She liked Rosie, or maybe she just felt pity for her. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw that Rechiza made a surprised face at the sight of a stranger, had she dealt with Prime's clones before? Interesting, but was it really that weird? The empire was large and existed for millennia. Not only Nayrlathotep's minions could have infiltrated it, or at least explored it… She stepped into the vehicle.

"Hello ... I haven't seen anyone who belongs to your species yet." she said smiling at the clone who was confused hearing her words.

"I am Wrongdak, actually Wrong Hordak. And… my brothers' history is very complicated." he said, oozing guilt

"And probably very interesting." Rechiza muttered quietly, entering after her.

"If you're going with Miss Bina, we'll find plenty of time to get to know her." she said, ignoring Lashunti's remark. Arkan-tar entered last. He stared at Bina intensivelyShe snorted softly. Maybe the woman was attractive, but not that he couldn't take his eyes off her…

"And what exactly are we going to do with him?" Asked quite young and already partly cybernetized Dragonkin. She glanced at

his companions. The short-cropped elf girl covered in tattoos of burning roses stared at her with hostility. A red-haired girl covered in orc or goblin tattoos and wearing lots of weird amulets looked around curiously. At the end there was a strange person with a dust mask and googles over his eyes. Judging by the nervously wagging tail, it was Pahtra. She shuddered involuntarily. This species brought back unpleasant memories for her.

I must be dreaming. I got myself into being an educator for young people again. Can't I just for a moment forget who I am? she wanted to burst out laughing like a villain in a penny story.

"These are Alatar, Itel, Lilka and Eti. Bina said.We'll deal with Mr. Wrongdak later. One problem at a time."

Yes, one problem at a time. For now, I have to get through this day.

Revelation

"Okay, we're making a stop for food and pee." Bina exclaimed. They'd been driving for two hours now, and apparently they'd already seen the observatory, at least as they looked through the visors. They were between hills covered with long yellow grass. Rosie was glad, because it was stuffy and smelled of sweaty bodies in the overcrowded Crushey, so she needed to get some air. Also, she needed to pee because she drank two bottles of water. So when the transporter stopped she went to the side (Lilka and Arkan-tar too) and after everything she returned to the others. The young friends and Bina were just preparing food, mostly sandwiches or self-heating portions. Lilka distributed the treats to Wrongdak and Rosie's companions, though Miss Daisy refused them, staring grimly at the horizon. On the highest hill was the observatory. Its rune-covered shield was majestic, and she could almost see the discharges of power dancing across its surface.

Suddenly she felt a hand on her shoulder and turned around in fear, Behind her stood Eti.

"Hey Sparkle Fimgers. I brought you a sandwich." she said, holding out to her a sliced flatbread with sausage and pickles in the middle.

Before she took it, Rosie said.

"You know that all you need to do is clap your hands to get my attention?

Eti shrugged.
- I don't know. And anyway, I don't like to clap."she waved a metal hand in front of Rosie's face.

Rosie started to eat and only now realized how hungry she was. She started eating the sandwich. Eti wove a dried sausage into her hand, then rolled back her hood and took off her mask and

glasses. She looked odd for a Pathra, but she wasn't ugly at all. The others gave her surprised looks. Eti didn't seem to pay attention to them, though she was clearly tense. She pricked up her ears and played nervously with the end of her braid. After a moment, they looked away, apparently mistaking her for some unknown race. The exceptions were Wrongdak and, surprisingly, Miss Daisy. Suddenly, the white-skinned alien ran up to the ranger and grabbed her by the shoulders.

"Catra?! What are you doing here?! Don't you recognize me? It's me Wrong Hordak! What happened..." he didn't finish, because Eti clenched her metal fist and, hissing like a cat, hit him in the stomach. Wrongdak doubled over, clutching his stomach. Eti came up to him all burgundy with anger.

"First…" she began, but Alatar cut her off.

"We don't start counting by showing the middle finger." he said without interrupting his meal, as if a fit of rage was nothing strange.

"First of all, no one dares to touch me without my permission. Secondly, I don't know how you could have confused me with anyone else? I am absolutely unique and exceptional. Third, what kind of Kitthra again? Do I remind you of a flea-infested pet? You must be a bigger fool than I thought to see anything feline about me." she was wagging her cat's tail violently and flattening her’s evidently cat's ears

"He doesn't seem to have a self-preservation instinct. Maybe that's why it was so valuable? A species devoid of self-preservation must be on the verge of extinction. "Alatar wondered. Lilka nodded. Bina got up and, beaming with anger, approached the ward.

"Eti… Eterna! March to Crushey and don't even dare move from there!" Bina screamed, absolutely enraged. Without a word, Eti marched to the vehicle, and the woman with burgundy hair helped the Wrongdak stand up.

"Are you okay?" she asked with concern.

"Yes!" said the alien, smiling happily, as if nothing had happened to him.

"I'm sorry for Eti... She can be unpredictable sometimes..." There was shame in Bina's voice.

"Don't worry... I just mistook her for my friend. She also doesn't like having her personal space invaded." he said with a strangely dreamy expression.

He mistook her for a friend? Rosie thought in surprise.

The only time she'd experienced such a shock had been seeing Mikah alive in the Brightmoon Throne Room. Even when she awoke on cursed Aucturn, in front of an Outer God, she was not so shocked. Deep down, she knew that her act would have consequences, though she didn't expect that she wouldn't run from them even after death.

Catara?! Here?! So far from Etheria? What happened to your hand? she wanted to exclaim, but she thought better of it. It wasn't Catra. This girl is taller than her, though not as muscular. Her hair was straight and greasy, dyed white and red, with visible dark red roots. Her complexion was darker, and her eyes were golden with occasional blue flecks. And that arm... It wasn't just a prosthetic arm, and she was absolutely sure she felt the flow of power when she hit the Wrongdak. The girl was scolded and sent to this nasty vehicle as punishment. *Well, I'd be a lot stricter on Catra* She felt a strong push in her back.

"Find a girl your own age!" she heard from behind the squares and turned around. She saw a green-haired girl, an elf covered in tattoos. She summoned a silver blade, so she was a Solarian…

"Be careful girl. People better than you have thought twice before raising a hand against me." she warned, but the solarian just

smiled indulgently at her, as if she was the one talking to the wayward kid. Her two present companions stood up and looked in their direction.

"And better ones than you lost a paw when they raised it on us." the girl growled.

"Oh, realy?" she replied coldly. She could teach that stupid girl humility... She was powerful enough to do that... Did she want it though? *Yes, in the past I would have made her regret her threats… But should I go back to being who I was. This is a chance. A second chance for me* She turned away from the Elf and walked a little farther and leaned against a stone standing apart, ignoring the triumphant "Ha." She had to think things over alone before will return to Lady Cala.

Dilayla took off her armor to let her sweaty body cool down for a while. She drank an army isotonic drink from her own supply but accepted a packet of soy noodles in green sauce, nothing special but quite tasty she had to admit, though maybe it was just that she hadn't had anything to eat since their late breakfast. She thoughtfully watched the white-skinned creature, who was talking suspiciously cheerfully with his motley droid, who, however, seemed to be more interested in the girl in the vehicle than his companion. Wrongdak, because that was name of this strange creature, looked like, didn't care much for the blow that strange Pahtra had dealt him... She didn't understand the girl's reaction, not fully. She had seemed to treat him contemptuously before, calling him Wormdak, and now she attacked him as if he had hurt her. Maybe he did… She looked at Itel, who was threatening Miss Daisy for some reason, who looked at the solarian as if she wanted to electrocute her if she could. "These are the children of war, and this was war against an enemy that cannot be defeated". She had never fought The Swarm, though mercenaries who agreed to do so were given five times as many credits It wasn't a fight with any rules. You just had to kill more of them, a lot more than they killed us, or hope that someone would use some secret method to drive them away, which happened more than once. Rechiza sat down beside her and asked quietly.

"What do you think about all this?"

The half-elf sighed heavily.

"I'm a hired gun. Nobody pays me to use what's i have between my ears. I am a simple creature."

The crippled Lashunt looked at her seriously, then at Wrongdak.

"This alien… I have some information about his species…" she said in a conspiratorial tone.

"Ya, you mean the attack on Minitar?" asked the mercenary and turned towards the astonished Lashunti smiling rakishly.

"Did you hear about this event?"she asked, not hiding her surprise. Dilayla burst out laughing.

"I am from Minitar, my dear, and I know firsthand what they can do." she said, and waved her own prosthesis.

Rechiza watched her for a moment with her metal eyes.
Iomadae... Our parts could make a nice robot.

"And you're not doing anything about it?" Lashunti said sharply.

"Well, I tried to kill Wrongdak, that's his name. But then I was attacked by a band of Veskas led by Azlanti."

Lashunti looked more and more funny as she was constantly surprised, almost cute in fact.

"And you didn't tell anyone about it?" she shouted.

"I'm doing it right now." she said with a heavy sigh. "I must admit I don't know what to think about him. Maybe he can masterfully play charming like our Lady Cala, but somehow I don't want to believe it. At worst, it was a very fresh clone when Prime fell."Dilayla said thoughtfully.

"He fell? Prime? How…" Rechiza was in such a shock that the mercenary thought that Lashunti would soon have a heart attack.

"The dude was broadcasting megalomaniac goddamn messages on our planet. I've heard a few and believe me, I've never experienced such a dose of condensed madness, and I've seen a lot." she shook her head.

"And ... his death? What exactly do you mean by its downfall?"

"I don't know much, only what I managed to understand from Wrongdak's statements He was annihilated a few years ago and very definitively. He fears him and hates him at the same time… Even now… How do you know about them?"

Rechiza thought for a long time about her answer, and then spoke very slowly.

"I got information from Liktor Janos di Vi..."she was saying, but the half-elf waved her hand.

"Yes, good old Janos di Vir. He saved most of me and a piece of my sister. If you're interested, I studied at the ordert for a while, but it wasn't my way. Well, i don't think anyone expected that any of the participants of this expedition had sincere intentions ... Anything else?" Dilayla smiled, but her eyes remained as cold as ice.

"This girl... her hand... She's covered in First Ones symbols. I don't think anyone has seen them except me... And I k- now what it says... *Here is the Punishing Hand, created to...* and I then can't see it because it ends." Lashunti said softly.

"Wonderful, but I'm guessing those First Ones are all extinct, so it's nothing to worry about." she grunted and began to lick the bottom of the box.

"Unfortunately, but you're right, they all died out." Lashunti murmured softly.

Eti already felt calmer… In fact, she felt sad, as she always did after she got mad. It was just the blemish that had been forced into her. It wasn't as bad as Rainy Days. It'll be over soon, as soon as he starts doing something, it's always been like that. She wasn't mad at Bina, who sent her to Crushey. She was also a little ashamed of the attack on Wormdak, but only a little. He shouldn't have touched her, implied she had anything to do with the cat, let alone talk about that one. Suggesting that there was more than one like her… She instinctively began whistling a song, irritating and painful to the ears, arousing anxiety, even fear in the listeners. Was she born knowing it, or was it stuffed into her head like everything else? Bina forbade her to whistle, but since she was alone ... Almost alone, but a person who entered Crushey would hardly complain about this melody, or about any other.

"Hi, Eti." said Sparcle Fingers smiling friendly. "How are you."

"I whistle, I digest, I breathe." she answered quietly and yawned "And how are you, Sparcle Fingers?" she asked with a great effort of will, forcing herself to be polite.

"Well, nothing new. Wrongdak doesn't mind your…outburst. He actually looks quite pleased. I don't quite understand why. I think you're look like his friend…" said the white-haired girl, but she interrupted her with a snort

"Because it's as dull as a shoe on my right foot, and I'm…i was left-handed. It is impossible for me to resemble his friends, because I am absolutely perfect, awesome and most importantly, unique." she murmured. Sparkle Fingers frowned.

"No one is perfect, everyone has flaws and you have to accept them." she said, staring at her with pretty blue eyes.

"Phrases that all imperfect people repeat to hide their imperfection." Eti said. She frowned and jumped at Sparkle Fingers which made a very strange sound.

"What are you doing?!" the girl asked in sign language, moving away from Eti.

"I'm checking how you smell. If I'm going to travel with you and your companions, I need to know how you smell." she said. Sparkle Fingers made a disgusted expression.

"It's strange ... and a little disturbing ..." she pondered "How do I smell?" she asked. Eti thought for a moment.

"Sweat, Almond suntan oil, pickles, smoked bacon and something I'm not sure of…. But mostly sweat.{said Eti – Not so bad, it's important that you don't use camphor. I hate camphor!" almost burst out laughing and Sparkle Fingers smiled as if what she said was really funny. She liked this girl. She seemed so happy and fascinated by the world, as if she could forget for a moment how lousy life can be.

" So you're really an intern, not an *intern…* - she lay down on the floor of the vehicle.

Sparkle Fingers moaned, or rather made a sound that was supposed to be a moan.

"Why would anyone think I'm…something like that!"

Eti shrugged

"You're a pretty girl on frontiner planet who obviously doesn't look like an adventurer or someone wealthy who could afford a bodyguard, and you're following a menacing-looking and also pretty woman. The conclusions suggest themselves." she asked the white-haired girl who blushed.

"That means I'm pretty too." she asked.

Before Eti could answer anything, she saw the Dumbot clumsily sneaking up on Crushey.

"What is Dumbbot looking for here?" she asked gruffly.

"The Dumnbot stared at her with its one eye in fascination."

"Why are you being mean to her?" Rosie asked indignantly. "Emily is nice!" she looked at the scars on the metal cover.

It doesn't have to be her... it could be any predator... she thought, then looked at her left, mutilated hand.

Previously it could have been a coincidence. Something completely unrelated to me. But now, after what Wormdak had done… He must have recognized her. He knew that one, even said her name. He was friends with her. So she's alive. She had a nice happy life, not like mine. She clenched her fists, feeling the cold fire in her veins.

"Hey Eti, what's up? Bina sent me here too because I snapped at that old Grim Lady because she was undressing you with her eyes." Itel said as she sat down beside her.

"I do not think so. Grimmy looks too sour to be interested in such things." she said quietly. Rosie stood up and, bowing to them, turned to Durnybot.

"Come on... I'll introduce you to Miss Daisy. She waved at them and left.

I've always been a blind fool she thought as she looked at the fallen blades of that nasty grass. *And that in every way... I've always seen Catra as a foundling, a worthless piece of junk found by Adora. A useful tool, useful in conditioning her sister* She stared at the vehicle, wondering what this unexpected revelation meant for her. *I've always contempt of her… no, it wasn't contempt. It was hate… For not being able to control her. For interfering with my beautiful plan to shape Adora the way I wanted. For being so like me…* She laughed nervously, and Arkantar looked at her in surprise. *I have to stop laughing to myself or they'll really think I'm crazy.* she sighed. Today, she wasn't even in control of her own life now. Adora and all of Etheria could shape

their own future, and the only one she could really hate was herself. But that girl, this Eti... She was very similar... like a younger sister... She was sure no one could get out of Despondos, as Hordak said, it was much easier to get there. She had too much evidence to back that up, so she had to belive him… Which meant Catra had also been born somewhere in the galaxy. The immensity of this fact made her head spin. *Through my pride I missed something so important, contempt and arrogance clouded my judgment.* Catra had always been almost as fit as Adora, and in some ways far more capable. Smart, rarely ill, immune to pain...”Just out of curiosity, I should look at her research results more closely. Surely someone noticed something, but preferred not to bother Hordak’s Right Hand with matters related to the difficult kid. But that was the past, she can't change that. Now she had to think about what the future would bring. If they were going to Etheria together, a confrontation would be imminent and potentially… She had no idea what to expect, she'd known this girl for only a few hours. From a pragmatic point of view, she was a valuable asset. She's not sure how this strange teenage girl will react to this discovery, but Catra… She should be happy… *Or not. There is a similarity between them, not only in appearance. Where did she grow up? Who shaped her? I need to learn as much as I can before they reach Etheria…and she should have a plan by the time they meet Lady Cala.*

"Miss Daisy, I have someone to introduce you." Rosie Pearl stood before her. The girl was smiling happily and pointing at Entrapta's droid. "This is Emily. Emily, this is Miss Daisy."

She smiled slightly and knelt in front of the droid.

"Hello Emily."'= she said. Usually her voice sounded a little different than it used to, but now she tried to make it sound old. Emily stared at her for a long moment, then squealed loudly and jumped away from her. Rosie looked at her in amazement.

"Sometimes children, animals and droids are afraid of me." she said and added in her mind *But for different reasons*

She approached Emily, who wanted to leave her, and spoke very quietly.

"We'll be traveling together on the same ship for a while. Just like your friend. Don't be afraid of me, I won't hurt you...unless you make me. *After all, I haven't forgotten how to be my old self.*

The secret of the observatory

Arkan-tar was confused, which he didn't do often, and he definitely didn't like the feeling. This Bina... she made him feel, for the first time in many years, that he didn't know what was going on. He was glad that Miss Daisy and Rechiza had managed to get a ship to take them to their destination… The crew, though young in age, seemed quite competent. Their captain was competent and able to control such an unruly pack.

But why did she look like Lady Ka? He might not have had the best opinion of the Lord Admiral's *Left Better Hand,* but who was he to judge her, everyone was entitled to their weaknesses, though he would have preferred her not to be his superior. When you work for someone as powerful as the Lord Admiral, even the slightest mistake could lead to the death of countless subordinates and innocents. This implied some problems, but there was absolutely nothing he could do about them.

But he had to make a decision about the captain of their new ship. At first glance, she seemed both older and younger than the Lord Admiral's Left Hand. He saw traces of life's hardships, stress and fatigue on her face. But her pupils weren't dilated, and she wasn't laughing withou reason. He didn't know much about Lady Ka, or rather, he didn't know anything about her, which was starting to worry him at the moment. His ancient superior hadn't given him much information about the Lord Admiral's entourage, but from what he'd heard about the commander-in-chief of their expedition, he might have expected the worst. Does Lady. Ka have a sister whom she commissioned to perform a task similar to ours. Maybe even their meeting with Rechiza and Miss Daisy wasn't so accidental after all, he wondered. The flaw in this reasoning was that the two members of their expedition, he and Lady Cala, knew her face, or rather half of it. Of course, he could be disposed of without much consequence, but Lady Cala had valuable maps, and besides, she had high-ranking friends on Carurystal ... Unless the woman's goal was to eliminate the entire expedition, which was an even more unpleasant thought ... then

why she would surround herself with such young and strange individuals. This, of course, could also be a trick to lull their vigilance, but then her charges should arouse trust? This quirky Pahtra was quite erratic, as was her elven pal who was threatening Miss Daisy. It was pointless to surround yourself with such individuals. So who was she, what did this strange encounter mean? He would need to talk to his companions as soon as possible. Rechiza spoke softly to Dilayla, listening thoughtfully to the mercenary's argument about the drows. He knew the half-elf's preferences, so he wondered if Rechiza shared them. If so, well, the odds that he'd be stuck with his own company throughout the journey were increasing. Well, maybe he should have befriended that half-drow?

"All right, we're there! We get off and plan!" Bina exclaimed. Their group, which in its equipment and appearance resembled a small company of mercenaries rather than a team of researchers, went outside. Bina ordered them to line up and began to speak.

"Listen, we want to break into this cursed building. Dusk is slowly approaching, although as far as I know most of us can see at night, and for the rest, including me, we have night vision goggles and flashlights. So you won't get lost. Enough from me, itel, now you!" she asked the elven Solarian."It's your idea, so you should explain to the others why we're here and tell them your plan.

The green-haired girl looked at the others, surprised and confused at the same time, clearly unprepared for this development. Arkan-tar stepped forward and bowed to the others very politely.

"Regarding the history and purpose of this building, I can help a bit." he said, and saw that Rechiza and Miss Daisy gave him a distrustful look. The others looked at him with a bit of curiosity mixed with amazement. Only the elf seemed to be pleased, because he gave her some time to work out a plan.

"So, as you can guess, we are all gathered here on this planet to discover the mysteries of the so-called Ravaged Zone. However, we are not the first to be fascinated by that place. Over a dozen

years, thanks to the support of various private investors and churches of Yaraesa and Desna, a huge Drift Observatory was built here to explore this mysterious area. For several years, research was carried out here and a lot of valuable data was collected. Unfortunately, for reasons that are difficult for us to understand, the center has lost its most important scientist. Shortly after, the resort closed, some say at an express pace. The locals did not know what had happened, but they left it alone, they even say that it is haunted. In my archaeological experience, it's usually wise to take this type of gossip seriously. We know that there may be maps and also astrographic data of large areas of the Zone, but we also have to reckon with many potential dangers…" he finished his lecture, and noticed with satisfaction that, apart from the red-haired girl with orc tattoos, no one fell asleep. Even the strange white-skinned alien and jeo droid seemed to listen to his reasoning.

"And is the identity of this scientist and his fate known?" Miss Daisy asked unexpectedly. He looked at her surprised. He adjusted his glasses and thought quickly about how much truth he should tell the others.

"It was Doctor Sidonius, the famous xenobiologist, historian and physicist. An individual of many talents." he said and suppressed a smile at the reaction of his companions. Rechiza looked away, hoping no one would notice her confusion, but the behavior of the crew of their nearly-future ship really surprised him. "Did he send them here? It raised more questions than answers." He thought.

"Indeed, a man of many talents. He must be a true genius or an ancient sage to have acquired so many skills." Miss Daisy smiled bloodthirstly and innocently at the same time. This woman was a bit disturbing even before he saw her real face.

"Why not both at once? He is a man of extraordinary intellect, and as a vampire he has spent centuries gaining knowledge." he bowed, smiling and went back to the line.

She wasn't too surprised by this, the bloody old vampire was researching the Prime’s Empire. Nothing could surprise her that day. Prior to her awakening, she didn't believe in the existence of vampires and ghosts, though she liked to tell Adora and Catra and the other cadets scary stories about ghoul princesses and blood-sucking princesses. Generaly about undead princesses. Most of them were legends she had learned in Mystacor or even at home, which she had later reworked for the use of the Horde. It wasn't until they stopped in Eox's orbit that she learned that the dead could walk among the living, and she accepted that truth. She herself was monster not much better than a ghoul, or even worse. After all, most of her nefarious deeds were the result of her conscious choices, not of a supernatural nature. *I wonder what a leech like that would think if it met a parasite like me? Do the undead scare each other with Power Devourers?*
This green-haired Elf Itel stood in front of them and began to outline her plans.

"Well, Eti will go to scout and ..." she wanted to say, but the girl with the metal hand interrupted her.

"We're taking Sparkle Fingers with us." she said crossing her arms first.

Itel glared at Eti, and Rosie took a step back.

"She is deaf and not from us!" the elf screamed, and Rosie took a step back. Bina and Rechiza gave Itel a stern look, but she ignored it.

"But can hear perfectly well, even when you whisper between each other ..." said the feline in a calm voice. Rechiza and Dilayla exchanged surprised glances, and Wrongdak nodded to her. The behavior of her companions was puzzling.

"But she doesn't even know if she's making noise..." Itel was speaking in a slightly calmer, though still annoyed tone, but Rosie cut her off.

"No, I can feel when I make noise because I can feel the vibrations and I can connect my glasses to your communicators so I will know what you are talking to me and I can switch the gloves to whisper." explained to the solarian.

You see, now that all your fanciful and absolutely irrational problems have been easily solved, we can start planning now." Eti said, and Dragonkin and Bina gave her a surprised look. The elf clenched her fist furiously and obviously wanted to continue the argument, but then decided it was time to intervene, because this discussion could go on forever. Besides, she liked Rosie, unlike Itel, so she decided to side with the deaf girl.

"Given the size of our company, it's best to split up into four groups of three." Eti, Itel and Rosie are the most skillful. Eti has good hearing and smell, Rosie, like many deaf people, has keen eyesight. And itel has innate leadership skills so it will be good to lead the three of you." She did not fail to tickle the green-haired girl's ego. Rosie looked at her gratefully, and Itel frowned suspiciously. "Mister Wrongdak looks like a strong and capable fighter, so does Lilka, so they can accompany Dilaylia as a strike force. - When she mentioned the clone, Eti looked at her like she was an idiot. "Alatar and Arkan-tar are gifted in matters of technology, so together with Captain Bina they will be technical support And I, Rechiza and Ireanis as powerful magic users will support everyone with their power. And Emily will watch over our transport during this time. " she said and watched with satisfaction as everyone looked at her silently. She looked at the elf and smiled slightly. *That's How It's done darling*

Itel tried to control her rage. She had to have a clear mind, because the success of her mission depended on it. And in addition to the usual problems with taming Eti's unpredictable behavior, she also had to look after a stupid deaf girl. Not that she didn't like Rosie. This girl just annoyed her, and the fact that she was trying to be nice to everyone made it even worse. She didn't know if she was so dumb she didn't understand it or if she was up

to something. Just in case, she didn't trust her any more than the rest of the guys Bina picked up. And Eti liked her. This Eti who lashed out at others for trying to touch her, or for saying she had cat ears, as everyone had seen recently. And that bloody grim elf who was staring at her friend as if she was seeing a cat girl for the first time. Of course, she must have seen the chimera of a pahtra and a human for the first time, but that didn't excuse her. pervert hag! And then she pretty much single-handedly took the leadership from her and put everyone in the corner. As if she'd ever seen a war up close, rather than babysitting some pampered damsel. And Bina, of course, said nothing, as always. *Didn't she understand the importance of their mission? That this is not a mere teenage whim, or even an ordinary treasure hunt. The fate of trillions of beings, perhaps even the entire galaxy, depended on the success of this enterprise. So few know what it takes to defeat the Swarm…* She thought and groaned in frustration. Eti and Rosie looked at her in surprise. She forgot that the deaf girl *hears* her through the communicator.

"Something happened?" Rosie asked, looking at her with concern.

"Nothing, turn your headphones down." she said trying not to show how angry she was.

They reached the fence. It was tall and thick, and there was barbed wire on top. Ordinary robbers would have to work hard to get to the other side. She and Eti were well equipped to overcome such an obstacle, and she saw the jump that the white-haired girl made today. "I wonder if she'll make it this time, too."
Eti turned on the cloaking field, doing the famous disappearing trick, and took off. Rosie started running too, her legs flashing and she took a leap. To her surprise, the white-haired girl found herself on the wall and turned to shake Eti's hand, but the shooter simply climbed on the flat surface thanks to her falcon boots. Then the wire began to wrap around Rosie's legs and Eti's arm. She cursed softly under her breath in Elvish and activated her jet boots while summoning the moonblade. She flew over to the girls, being careful not to burn them, and cut the living wire with quick

cuts, because that was the name of what was trying to capture them. Soon all three were on the other side.

"Are you all right? " she asked. Rosie shook her head, but Eti growled as she looked up. She lost the glove that protected her left hand. Even in the shadow of the setting sun, her maimed fingers were visible. The deaf-mute girl covered her mouth at the sight, looking at Eti in astonishment.
"It's off to a good start." Eti grunted.

He had trouble concentrating on the task at hand. He wasn't sure what it was exactly, just like his new friend Lilka. So he left the decision-making to his next new friend Dilayli, who seemed to know what they were doing, whatever it was. In general, he had made a surprising number of friends during the day, which made him extremely happy. From the time he came to this planet he had only Emily, now he was surrounded by extremely interesting people ... And one of them was her. For a brief moment he was sure it was Catra. He was terrified that something terrible must have happened to her here. She didn't recognize him, and worse, she had lost her arm in some terrible way. For a moment, he was terrified that she'd been chipped again, which was scary in itself, but it would also mean that he... that Horde Prime had returned. He couldn't put into words how scary that would be... but it wasn't Catra... He had trouble distinguishing faces, it wasn't a skill He expected his brothers to have... Over the years he had learned to recognize Skittermanders because they were his friends, and the Vesks, whose honor might be offended by a mistake, but he still had problems with other races. But he was sure they were very similar, as Emily confirmed, and she had no trouble recognizing the others. It meant… he wasn't exactly sure what it meant, but it was something amazing.

"The area is clear" Itel's voice came over the communicator. They were standing in front of a heavy gate leading into the interior of this observatory. It felt so strange to be standing in front of a structure built just to explore his empire. If he ever found out

about it, he would probably come here to destroy everything just for idle curiosity.

"Do you see an electronic lock or something?" the woman in power armor asked.

" I see, but for now there is no power, so than it will not give us." Itel said in a matter-of-fact tone. " Are you waiting for Alatar and the others? she asked, but Lilka shook her head and started to take a laser cutter out of her backpack, so Dilayla replied "No, we'll manage faster on our own."

"Okay, just be careful, they've put a living wire here, there may be more traps!" she called. Dilayla looked at the two of them and motioned for them to come over.

"It'll only take a minute." said Lilka and put on a protective mask. He felt a surge of longing for Entrapta at the sight. As much as he liked his friends from Vesk III, he was eager to return home, especially since he had such wonderful news for all of them. Entrapta was right, and so was his brother. Prime didn't conquer the entire galaxy, his empire was just a small part of the universe that hadn't actually heard of him. The Galaxy was sure of things, wonderful and terrible, and above all, extraordinary. Though he stayed mostly in one skittermander's town on Vesk III, he had heard many tales of all sorts of wonders in the universe. He couldn't wait to be able to "Bring all collected data on the universe" to Entrapta and his brother. And now this girl...

"Are there many of you?" Dilayla's question snapped him out of his thoughts. He blinked a few times before answering.

"I have no idea…" he said truthfully "There were several thousand of us in the place that became my home… But I don't know how many of us there were in the whole empire or what happened to them." He felt a sudden pang of sadness. Unlike the Older Brother, his bond with the clones had been strong, at least when he left Etheria, but he had thought little of them in the last few years, other things on his mind. Now he was starting to worry.

"Is this one of your coins?" she asked, tossing him a coin, which he caught on the fly. On one side was the symbol of the Horde, albeit gold on red background, and on the other was the words "United We Shall Cast Out Shadows." He felt blood rushing to all parts of his body.

"He... Horde Prime didn't use coins. He didn't need them. He just took what he wanted." he said. He had no idea where Dilayla had gotten that coin, but the mere prospect that something of Horde Prime had survived…that some of his brothers might still be enslaved… The power-armored warrior looked at him in perplexity.

"I didn't expect it to have such an effect on you. At first I wasn't sure where I knew the symbol from, but then I remembered. This coin was owned by Shirkas, a certain Shiren miner who wandered deep into this whole Ravaged Zone. He found some ore there and met two beings. One of them was a drow priestess… Do you know who a drow is? - she asked a bit thoughtfully.

"Black Elf…?" he asked surprised.

"No... There are black elves, see Ireanis, and Itel are also dark-skinned... Drows are something else... Very nasty usually, though not always of course. I've worked for them twice and it wasn't a pleasant job...but to the point. This woman paid him for his work with these coins, though they appear to be fake and of little value. He had met some monster before... He looked like a woman with a purple octopus attached to her head... Her tentacles were growing like hair from her head..."

For a moment he did not know what the woman was talking about, he had already learned that the universe was full of terrible and terrifying beings. Sam fought Skitterwander, for which he even got a medal. It took him a moment to realize who the woman was talking about.

"NO! She is no monster! She is a wonderful and very smart woman! She gave me the name. She freed…" he spoke agitatedly, but Dilayla placed an armored hand on his shoulder.

"You were there! Where we're going." she said, and now he realized he had said a few words too much. *My brother told me to be silent! I promised not to tell anyone. So far he's been successful…* Dilayla looked around, but Lilka was finishing burning through the gate, and the rest were deep in conversation. She put her hand on his shoulder and looked him in the eyes

"Did the people of this place… Did your friends defeat Horde Prime? The one who took everything I had? she asked, and he, still shaken, just nodded."

"Okay... I promise I won't tell anyone, but beware. None of my comrades are who they say they are. And we're hiding a secret.... Trust none of us, especially the beautiful Lady Cala. - she said seriously and smiled. "If you can be friends with someone who tried to kill you on the same day, then let me call you your friend."

He answered her with the friendliest smile he could muster.

"My friends have tried to kill each other many times and now they are together."

The blue-haired woman laughed loudly and sincerely.

"Don't count on it, I prefer girls. But it's nice to have at least one friendly face on this trip."

"I didn't expect anything, and I'm glad you consider me a friend."

"Mr. Wrongdak, Mrs. Dilayla, please help me push." Lika called. They both went to help her.

She was standing next to the other two sorceresses when she saw from a distance that Wrongak and the mercenary were smiling at each other.

"And what happened?" Rechiza said, frowning. *I wonder how much she's seen with those metal eyes of hers.*

"Oh, don't you understand? Can't you feel love in the air?" Ireanis called. The lashunti looked at the silver-haired sorceress as if she were an idiot, but the other woman didn't seem to notice. Although it's very possible that most people looked at Ireanis that way on a daily basis, so it probably seemed normal.
How such a person ended up in such a place and is now taking part in an expedition on whose success so much depends, I have no idea. she thought. The elf was actually not a stupid woman. she had learned to recognize such people after making so many mistakes.. She definitely considers herself a sorceress, and a very talented one. But she had serious doubts about it…

"For many years, one of my many tasks was… supervising students in a military school, and I had to learn how to distinguish between friendship and infatuation." *And how to ruin both if necessary*

"Military school? I thought you only taught young ladies. You are a person of many talents as i see." Lashunti said smiling.

"Some people will do absolutely anything to survive." she said in a gloomy tone.

The witchwarper gave her a sideways look but said nothing because Ireanis interjected.

"Yes, I remember once distributing elxirs for hair growth after I lost my job at the university.

Why am I not surprised she thought with bitter satisfaction, but asked politely.

"I take it that this potion worked perfectly, guaranteeing a full head of hair?"

"Well, it worked, but it usually made you bald..." explained the silver-haired elf with an absolutely sincere smile.

That doesn't surprise me at all either.

"Oh." was all she said.

"Do you think we can expect magic traps there?" asked her a lashunti.

„I would leave traps out of sheer malice if I were to lose what I care about… if I even thought that someone might dare todid it. It hadn't occurred to me last time, I was so confident."

"If they had the time, and the things they keep here are worth wandering off-road for, there must be plenty of traps here." Any sane person would do that.
Rechiza smiled sarcastically.

You have a wonderful definition of sanity - she murmured.

"With failures comes wisdom... Come on, they're opening the gate right now..." she said and headed towards the observatory.

Eti had a bad feeling. Well, she always had a bad feeling. She had worse feeling She felt bad being outside without a glove. She didn't want anyone to see her disability. Everyone thought she regretted losing her organic hand, but her new metal one was much better, though she missed her claws. She could cut even metal with them, not to mention flesh and bone. *Oh yeah, not to mention flesh and bone.* She clenched her left fist. *And that's why I was hurt. Naughty cats have their claws clipped.*

"And how, do you see the generator?" Itel called over the communicator.

"I think so, I'm just going to check it out." she said uncertainly.

"Okay, just focus and don't let yourself get distracted. A lot depends on it, we cannot fail." her friend recommended.

"All right." she said and added quietly under her breath after silencing the communicator "I'm glad you don't put too much

pressure on me.
Itel had been annoyed ever since Grimmy took over. She was always nervous when she approached the possibility of realizing one of her plans, but this time it was worse than usual. She guess it was her fault. It had something to do with her insisting on taking Sparkle Fingers. She just didn't understand how anyone could have a problem with Sparkle Fingers. She was nice.

The generator was in a small shed. It was padlocked, but with just a few hand blows using a little energy, the padlock broke. The generator was simple enough, but it was the kind that would run for decades on the frontier without proper technical support. She can definitely run it. She was sure of it, she had learned that, as almost everything, by the twentyth day of her life. When they did IT to her. She shook her head to shake off such thoughts. They weren't good, they brought nothing but pain. She looked around and found a tank of high-energy biofuel. They were sealed, so it was definitely still usable. She grabbed the canister, cursing her maimed fingers, and poured the thick, slimy liquid into the tank, then turned a few knobs and turned the device on. She heard the loud whirr of machinery working. Through the vent, she saw light entering the room, so the power was restored.

" Okay, everything works! Now it's time for you Alatar." she said to everyone on the communicator.

"Be careful. Creatures living in the dark do not like it when light disturbs their peace." she heard Grimmy's voice.

"Are you always so melodramatic?" she asked, looking around the brightly lit square in front of the building. Night was coming, so a little light might be useful, at least to others.

"You're probably right…" Grimmy replied as with a bitter laugh.

Arkan-Tar walked next to Dragonkin, and his exocortex collected data. This place was not an ordinary research institution of a team

of scientists there. The being who managed this used the knowledge gathered by the millennium of existence to build this shield covered with this runes. "Let's add the knowledge without context. That's what all this is about, "he thought, thinking about why no one had undressed this monumental device. Locals may have no funds for this, nor would they know what to do about it. However, there were enough powers in the universe that could make use of this device.

"Alatar, you can now connect to the local network, do you have to connect to your computer?" Bina asked looking around the center.

Dragonkin shook his head, which looked quite strange in the case of a being with such a long neck.

"Theoretically yes, but I would have to use some of the power, and I don't have much left." he said in a slightly apologetic tone.

" I think we have to enter the main building. Fortunately, i have a simple password breaker, it's quite a useful toy." Arkan-tar proposed to his companions.

"I didn't know that haker skils were usefull to archelogists." Bina said, raising an eyebrow.
- It depends on the archaeologist. Most mainly dig in the ground, but people like me often prefer to obtain information in a slightly more unusual way. - He said a bit theatrically spreading his hands.

"Yhy, unusual you say." she said, looking at him dragged on. "Itel check if you have any alarm at the door, as you need to ask the shock team to provide you with a cover. She turned to the elf.

"I can't even embrace my absolutely perfect mind, how a Wormdak can cover us, but as you know, I'm extremely nice, a gentle and conciliatory person who never wants to start conflicts." she put in Eti through the messenger.

"Yes, you are the personification of pacifism and love of your felows." Bina murmured, but Itel confirmed that she had heard the command.

He came closer to the bina so that they could talk a bit more privately.

"Do you look after an extraordinary bunch for a long time?" he asked, raising an eyebrow.
Bina looked at him approximately.

"It will be five years. I have been dealing with them since Kesler's fall." she said and her eyes burst a bit when she plunged into the memories. "Miraculously we managed to save from theswarm. The Shadows of Tarak did help us..."she looked at Alatar, who probably was looking for a signal, with motherly sensitivity. "I am their only family, everything they have ..." she rubbed her eye and asked. |And how much do you know doctor Leech?"

Now she surprised him, he wasn't sure if she just didn't want to find him, but this time he also decided to take a chance.

"It will also be five years. He also made the eyes of Rechiza, although she does not know about our familarity." he said smiling apologetically. - Bina just nodded thoughtfully. They waited forfew minutes in silence and finally heard Itel's voice.

- It's all right inside." Elf said.

They headed towards the main building. The windows were made of some very durable material that did not get dirty. It seemed that the whole building was almost self -sufficient, probably in the interior there was a fusion reactor ensuring the power supply of the observation disc and the rooms for employees who probably did not leave this place for weeks,

They three went inside into. They found themselves in a spacious lobby, which seemed not to fit into such a somp. Saltmarsh. A strange alien, even stranger girl covered with orc tattoos, and Dilayla were inside. He didn't see three scouts. White -skinned bowed kindly, and the girl searched the garbage bucket for her only known purpose.

"Itel, this green -haired elf, noticed that this corridor leads to the main computer room." she said the half -elf, wiping her light blue hair. "But probably everything is safe, because if it was different, we would hear shots and screams."

"And explosions. Eti likes to make explosions." Red -haired said. He smiled and nodded. The corridor was illuminated by a weak blue glow that would not offend being who hate sun. After a while they came to the room where most of the computers were located. The most valuable data was probably on the internal computer, cut off from the local network of the research center or even on analogue media ... but they only looked for maps. Nobody would be such a paranoid to set traps protecting the results of the research and not tell them about it ... right?

When they entered, Rosie waved them smiling cheerfully.

"I guess everything is right? But what exactly are we looking for?" she asked and began to look around, as if she had just realized why she actually found herself here.

"Map ... maps of the Ravaged Zone and something else ..." Itel said, walking along the circle formed from the monitors. In the middle there was a holographic display. A fairly popular style of office design in places where a rather authoritarian management model was preferred. This bizarre feline was sitting on a chair with her legs on the table, and lazily stared at the screensaver. Somewhere she lost the glove and now held her hand on the armrest rolled up her fingers.

Alatar approached one of the computers and connected a flash drive offered to him by Arkan-tar. He began to tap his claws on the keyboard.
"Okay, I got access. There is some looped transmission to play. Run it?" he asked after a while.

"Yeah!" Verthani recommended, although he knew what they would see ...

The Smarty ordered Alatar to turn on some transmission, so she got up from the chair and started staring at the holographic display, curious what she would see there. She never liked computers. They bored her, not counting simple shooting games, that can be operated with one hand. Itel went to her staring at the display, as if she were waiting, which truth she would reveal to them. After a moment of loading, a figure appeared to them. It was a woman, at first glance she took her as an Android, but after a while she came to the conclusion that she must be a cyborg, someone who underwent a very serious cyber -reconstruction. She saw something like that in a thousand daughters, or rather a thousand sisters, as they preferred to be called. They were even less, *alive* from Androids, because such a number of implants was difficult to control. She had to undergo huge changes, because her face resembled a rather porcelain mask. She saw that the fist stared at her absolutely shocked. Did she know her from somewhere? At the moment, a Grimmy with the other mystics entered the room.

"Here, Mistress of Armament Joan from Void Galeon *the Dreams of Eternity*. I speak on behalf of Captain Blazebringer." she said in a cool, emotionless voice. She felt that Itel was putting her hand on her shoulder.

"You see! He exists, really exists." The elf said with a strong emotions.

"We demand from the inhabitants of this planet to issue a individual known to us as Doctor Herlam Sidonius. If you refuse, we will use all available resources so that this person is on board. All resistance will meet our definite answer. We have armament able to destroy this planet, and even hurt your sun, although such means will not be needed ... Let the doctor wait for the first officer Vale in front of his observatory. Captain Blazebringer gives a word that nothing will happen to anyone if our demands are fulfilled."

And then the transmission was interrupted. She felt itel leaning on her shoulder. Tears flowed across the solarian's face.

"It's all true. We have a chance. If we cure him ..." she looked tenderly at Etia. She bowed her head as if she wanted to kiss her, but the shooter gently moved away. In the blue eyes of the elf you could see pain, but only for a moment.

"It was ... interesting." said the Smarty, adjusting the glasses. "Now download the maps. It seems that it will all be a lot more simply than I thought." When he said that, Alatar entered commands. Finally, the download began, and then the pandemonium began.

From several computers, glich gremlins jumped out, which began to run around and make fun. They broken with electric rays, made noise. They were dangerous when to unarmed Nerd caught up but not to them. She hit his fist in the nearest creature, rejecting him to the other end of the room, and then reached for the pistol and shot, turning him into a pixel cloud. Itel cut the nearest creature annihilating him.

- It's not as scary as for a thousand -year - old vampire, it was a rather malicious joke." Rechiza said, but then a dark being began to materialize over the display. She was tall with a look as some someone took out the bone from its body. She had round, teethless mouth and eyes ... these eyes were full of darkness ... Darkness from between the stars. Everything seemed to slow down, the sounds were muffled. She heard a quiet shout "Bodak!", but there was only darkness ... and then the words sounded. Full of power. Full of terror and might. Suddenly, the creature curled up and overstated until the walls trembled. His body bent and was torn to shreds that fell to the floor. Little of black smoke floated from them. She turned and saw Miss Daisy, who was breathing heavily after casting a spell.

"Thanks. she said almost brinnginga smile to her's face. The elf mystic also smiled, warmly and gently. She did not expect someone like her is able to do it. Sparks of joy shone in her eyes.

"You're welcome. " she bowed to her.
Then they heard the sounds of shots ...

The first clash of this war...

Calamity ran at speeds unattainable by more primitive creatures, her hair as bright as the rays of the rising sun floating in the air thanks to the momentum created by her movement. Her muscles did not tire, and her joints did not creak despite the enormous effort. With superhuman dexterity, she skipped obstacles like a child playing hopscotch, leaping between boulders, landing each time with the grace of a dancer, though such a feat would have shattered the bones of most mortals. She could run like this for hours, regardless of the heat, the particles of sand and salt whipping her face, and the fatigue. Rarely had she had the opportunity to unleash her power away from the envious gazes of lesser beings. She could take a break from their tiresome company, not hear the twittering about the crap that was about their twisted minds. Miserable desires, pathetic dreams, meaningless existence... Meat puppets who think they are better at something than petty vermin that they crushed as they rushed ahead. But there were mortals of some value. One of them was Shadow Weaver. She needed her to reclaim her destiny. Of course, it was through the cowardice and weakness of the dark sorceress that she lost them. *You are a weak and vile creature, and yet I must obey you, for such is the will of Crawling Chaos. Now I have to save your pathetic life! Will my torment ever end?* she thought, and kicked the neck of some desert predator unlucky enough to get in her way as she ran. „I'm better now” she thought.

She was furious. But she couldn't take her emotions out on those who caused them. "Damn followers of Charon. Had it not been for their attack, their ship would not have been seriously damaged. Then they set a trap for them and she lost two valuable servants. If it wasn't for that, they wouldn't have to play around with finding a replacement ship, and her position in the whole expedition would be much higher. And now she found out that her rivals had decided to use an opponent whose involvement they had not expected, though they should have, and whose

participation in the coming events could destroy all her plans. *Was that your plan? Would you, O Soul of the Outer Gods, use the wretched people of the Star Empire? Who in their hypocrisy used the Vesk mobsters. Pathetic* she thought. Fortunately in misfortune, the cult of Crawling Chaos was surprisingly strong on this ball of dirt and salt, and at the meeting the local *archblasphemer* had warned her though of course he had not spared her all the welcome ceremonies that mortals in their infinite ignorance considered essential. She wanted to rip off all of his limbs and feed them to him, but Shadow Weaver had taught her that self-control, the ability to focus on a goal and ignore distractions, was the true measure of greatnes...

She hurried back to the hotel room, only to find that stupid Ysoka there. She told her that in the last communication Verthani had informed them that they had managed to obtain a spaceship and were now going to an observatory to obtain additional information. They didn't seem to be aware of the danger that lay in wait for them. She happened to know where the observatory was supposed to be. The cultists had told her. They had an agent there, but he died mysteriously and was transformed into a terrible undead creature called a bodak. Well, that's what happens when fools play with powers beyond their comprehension... But a dark sorceress should be able to deal with that, the greater threat was the Azlanti. This is where her help may prove necessary. She just hoped she wouldn't ruin her dress. Losing one of them so early in the journey would be an irreparable loss. Unfortunately, when he enters a fight, that can happen.

She could see the great arcanic shield of the observatory. Even now she could feel the powerful energy pressed into brass and runes of alchemical silver. How much money was used to build a machine that turned out to be almost useless in general terms. She spotted three Azlanti soldiers. They were guarding the direct route to the research facility, probably acting as rear guards, making sure that no one could pass unnoticed their main force from the city side. She was late, but at least she had an idea of how to get rid of this minor problem. She closed her eyes and took a deep breath to become Lady Cala Grayskull for a moment.

Recall her character, way of moving and mannerisms. To become a well-mannered, but also a strong and self-confident woman from a wealthy family, whom everyone would gladly trust. It was so easy, at least if she only had to step into her skin for a short time.

She jumped and landed before the aeon guardsmen looked her way and leveled their weapons at her.

She jumped and landed in front of the Aeon Guardsmen, who looked her way and leveled their weapons at her.

"Please." she sobbed heavily, panting heavily, "Help me." he got down on one knee and lowered her head. Tears ran down her face. "Those Vesks, they're chasing me. Please save the human woman…" she burst into tears. The two soldiers stared into the distance for the enemies she was talking about, and the officer came over to help her up and wrap her cloak around her. He didn't even notice that the girl he wanted to help had a epee at his side. Even though she didn't need it. She hit him hard in the chest, shattering his sternum, and hurled it at one of the soldiers.

"For honor..." she cried, smiling wildly as she drew her sword. She jumped to the second soldier and pierced his heart.

"Of" she took out the blade in a fluid movement, while turning towards the last soldier, at whom she threw the officer. The guard tried to get up, but she stabbed him in the forehead with the blade. The blow was so strong that carurystal steel came out the other side.

"Graykull!" her scream carried over the yellowed grass. She took a deep breath and stretched her arms out to her sides. She closed her eyes, enjoying her strength.

"I've Power!"she cried, the wind blowing her hair.

Then the Azlant- officer she had forgotten about fired at her, hitting her in the face. She felt virtually no pain, just an unpleasant tug, then a tingling sensation as her tissue began to

regenerate. Calamity looked at the man with pure hatred. She imagined his helmeted eyes widening in disbelief, slowly turning to horror.

"You didn't think you could ruin my dress, you fool! - she cried, kicking his gun. She plunged the blade into his elbow and stamped on his crushed chest.

"A wretched, filthy worm. I could have ended your miserable and meaningless life quickly, but you upset me, so die slowly, and let every second of your agony remind you what a mistake you made." hhe stabbed him again, this time in the other elbow. Then, venting her anger, she smiled with tattered lips and headed towards the observatory, heading towards the sounds of the fight.

Banishing the bodak was exhausting, but she felt almost no fatigue. There was a completely different feeling in her heart that she hadn't known since leaving Mystacor… It was hope. *Even when I found Adora... Even then i felt a rather bitter satisfaction... A cold determination to make this child a weapon to redeem myself and take my revenge on those who stood in my way and forced me to become a monster.* Now she could find something more. Redemption. She saw that the girl, that Not-Catra, looked at her with gratitude, gratitude without the fear of a servant towards a cruel master. The normally sad face of this girl almost smiled. She felt euphoria welling up in her… But there was no time for that. She needs to focus, nothing, absolutely nothing can distract her because she is needed right now. "This time I'll be the weapon. I will protect her and everyone else," she said, feeling a new strength enter her.

Hearing the gunshots, Eti grabbed her rifle, and Arkan-tar did the same, showing that he was more than a barked swashbuckler. They ran out into the corridor. Wrongdak and Lilka crouched down to the ground. The clone looked worried, and the girl looked as if she was ready to face the entire power of the Horde... or the Swarm... by herself.

"Who's attacking us?!" exclaimed Dilayla.

"I don't know, I saw a flash and told him to get down. Wrongdak said." it's such a reaction.

The mercenary nodded.

"Stay away from windows and onto the ground." she said. Bina and most of her crew complied. But Rechiza and Ireanis stood staring at the windows, so she grabbed them by their robes and dragged them downstairs. Eti has disappeared somewhere. She wanted to follow her, but then two robots, humanoids with one arm converted into weapons, and a soldier in green armor burst through the door. Arkan-tar and Bina opened fire with a rifle and a pistol, shredding the nearest robot, but the second aimed at the scientist, but Dilayla grabbed his armed arm and fired up, hitting the ceiling. Dilayla hit him with her armored arm, crushing his shoulder on the weapon side. Meanwhile, Lilka and Itel attacked the soldier. She had seen a similar one once on a poster or in holovision, but she wasn't sure who it was. The Solarian wanted to confuse him and take his attack on herself, when Lilka struck from the side with a flaming ax, chopping off his arm.

"Wrongdak, throw that robot out the door before he fucks up, then get his guns." cried the mercenary. The clone threw the robot headfirst, then took the weapon from the wounded soldier. He held them expertly as befits a born warrior, though his expression was troubled. "Genetic memory is strong, but it can also be painful, isn't it?" she thought. Arkan-tar stood at the door and fired several shots, followed by the explosion of the destroyed robot and the cries of the wounded. Alatar tied the wounded soldier to the other robot, and Dilayla crushed another arm and leg. Then the woman signaled Wrongdak to follow her. She stood in front of the window.

"Damn, damned fucking Azlanti"! growled the mercenary. *Star empire? I would never expect them here… They are almost the worst that could happen to Etheria. The heart may have been destroyed… But the first left many other terrible secrets there*. she

thought. She didn't know much about the star empire, but it was something completely alien and frighteningly familiar to her.

"I saw four robots and ten Vesks. Several soldiers are hiding in the shadows. I hit one." Arkantar said. She nodded, wondering what to do. The strength and sense of power that filled her was the solution. She turned on the communicator and said.

"Give me cover, and they will know the horror of true darkness." she said to everyone.

"Melodramatism and pathos went out of fashion Grimmy." she heard Eti's voice through the communicator. She smiled.

She walked in it and forward like the Commander did when she was thinking about something difficult. She might not be as wise as Mind Brightener, but she knew very well how to deal with Wise Beings. Here she needed her skills to deal with a situation she had not yet found herself in. She was here. Lady Extinguisher of the Light. She remembered her well, though she didn't understand everything then. Now she knew that she wanted to broke down Mind Brightener and the Caretaker, but the Commander defeated her…then they stayed together for a while after the Caretaker took her to the enemy's stronghold. And finally she disappeared. It wasn't until some time later that the Designer said that S*he managed to escape it all into death. Now she is dead and can no longer be judged* She died, that is, she was Broke down, as happened to organic beings. Only organic beings could not be repaired so easily. She only found out about it recently when one of the Skittermanders broke down and nobody fixed it. When she asked through Friend if there was a way to fix it, she was told that it wouldn't be good. That *His time is fulfilled* Maybe a Mind Brightener or a Lightbringer could do that to make things right… But they were almost certainly not here. Who fixed her? How and why? She didn't understand, but she knew that Light Extinguisher was very dangerous. She said she wouldn't hurt her unless he forced her to. She didn't want to force her to do anything. She

didn't want anything to do with her, she didn't even want to be on the same planet as her. She wanted to tell her Friend about it, he should come up with something... Only if he comes up with something and she breaks him down? She didn't want Friend to be broke down. Just what does she want? She said they would travel together and they were going back to the Creation Place, does that mean she's going back there too? Will Brighteye and the Commander be happy that she's been fixed? She was to them what Mind Brightener was to her, so they should be happy. However, the Designer didn't like her, so she wasn't sure, but on the other hand, the Designer and the Commander didn't like each other either. But will anyone recognize her? She looked different... Even though she wore a face mask back then, as did Mind Brightener when she was working on something potentially dangerous... Though once Light Extinguisher never took it off... Why? Was she dealing with dangerous things all the time? She's dangerous herself, so maybe that's why she wore a mask?

It would probably be best if he waited to tell everything until he was back at the Place of Creation. There she will tell Mind Brightener and Desinger everything. They will surely know what to do...

"I hate bots." a voice growled, and the entire vehicle shook. She looked up. It took her a while to figure out that this machine could talk like Darla. She wasn't sure if he was a Wise Being, though, because he'd repeated the same phrase forty-four times and she had no idea what effect he was expecting… She wasn't sure what was expected of her, actually. Light Extinguisher told her to watch him, but she wasn't sure if she could do anything, her weapon was taken away from her. All she could do was walk here and think. And she had something to think about besides the Light Extinguisher. They met the Second Commander. It was similar but not identical. Same model but different series. And her hand was replaced with a very interesting part. The friend was delighted to meet her here, but she felt she should undergo a system reboot and maybe even a reinstallation of cognitive support systems. Mind Brightener would definitely help her!

She heard voices from outside. Someone was approaching the vehicle... She started tapping on the walls, wanting to alert the machine, though she didn't know what he could do. She must have succeeded, because the vehicle said.

"Bina! I see that three fools in front of the hood and I'm sure they're laughing at me. Yes, armed... Can I really? BUHAHAHA." the vehicle laughed. Sometimes Mind Brightener laughed like that, too, but this time it sounded scary... She felt the vehicle move so violently that she was thrown to the rear. She heard them hit something...

First, she summoned darkness around the three of them, making them harder to hit.

"We're covering the Spellcasters." exclaimed the mercenary. She started firing, as did the scientist and the clone. She quickly rushed through the door without waiting for the other sorcerers. She wasn't sure about Rechiza's skills, but she had suspicions that the only thing the silver-haired sorceress could do was draw fire on herself. She went out into the night. The black, gloomy sky was lit only by those accursed stars. But here on earth the research facility was brightly lit, and darkness swirled around her. She saw Vesks trying to hide among the nearest buildings. and robots ready to attack. The Azlantis continued to hide, confident that they would be safe there… She reached in that direction and shadowy tentacles shot out in that direction. She felt them roam reaching for the Aeon Guards, finding their victims and wrapping themselves around them. Her body surged with strength as the dark power drained the life from those she took. „This is the power I paid so much for." she thought. One of the commanders clearly saw what a threat she was, because despite the darkness surrounding her, she felt one of the Vesks almost hit her. However, in the direction of the enemies, the missiles of her allies flew. She saw that the lizard's hand, which appeared to be the commander, shattered as an unseen shooter shot him. Dilayla, Bina, and Arkan-tar also hit a few attackers, while Wrongdak probably

preferred to shoot at the machines. Someone gave the order, and the Vesks and the robots charged. Then Rechiza caused the ground beneath them to crack and collapse, a few lizards stumbled, others were engulfed in a fiery explosion called by the itel, but the robots seemed to ignore it.

And then Ireanis cast a spell. Lightning bolts shot out of the silver-haired woman's hand, something she knew so well, which hit the Azlantean machines. The discharges jumped from one to the other, knocking them to the ground. With all the robots destroyed, lightning strikes hit the Vesks, killing some and knocking the others down. Surprised, she looked at the elf, who was looking at them with a goofy smile. She held up her thumb, smoke pouring out of it. Then the sorcerer turned on her side. She dashed to it without breaking the spell to pick it up. But then she remembered something.
These robots are exploding...

The explosion knocked her to the ground as well.

The mystic zapped, the robots boom, and the Vesks didn't look good anymore. It was the only way Dilayla could comment on what had just happened. She thanked Iomadae for this change of fate and ran outside to pull the stunned and unconscious woman inside. Rechiza grabbed the gun and went inside.
"What a beautiful show our ladies put on!" Arkan-tar half-shouted, half-stated, aiming at the enemies through the half-open window.

"Dark magic. whispered Lashunti, looking at Miss Daisy.

Oh, realy?! thought the half-elf and said.

"Dark or not, was very useful."

"I agree, they are so funny writhing in agony, it needs to be recorded ... But we must hurry, because they will gather soon and then it will be bad." Eti interjected.

"I called the Crusher." Bina said. "We'll go out the back door and he'll be waiting for us."

Dilaya frowned.

"Isn't he a bit crazy?" asked the mercenary.

"It is, but in the way we need it." replied the Captain

"Move your butts, instead of insulting Crushey!"

Eti watched the spellcasting from above with her mouth open. She knew Ireanis could do interesting things sometimes, but Grimmy was amazing. Those screams and yells and all that darkness, it was something amazing… But the explosion was definitely an unpleasant experience. Her hearing was so muffled for a moment that she barely heard Sparkle Fingers coming. The girl stood next to her, cringing surprisingly professionally.

"I... I didn't know what to do, so I came to you to help you... Somehow." she said in sign language. She nodded and spoke to the half-elf mercenary. She motioned to Sparkle Fingers to follow her. She hoped they would end up in the same back door as the rest. Fortunately, they succeeded, and the whole group left through the wide door. Wormdak had finally made a good use of it, and was wearing a deliciously snoring Ireanis on his shoulder. This job clearly suited him. The Fist supported Grimmy, who looked around bewildered. She descended the vertical wall, and Sparkle Fingers jumped down.

"Was she hit hard?" she asked anxiously. Itel shot a suspicious glance at Sparkle Fingers. He fawns again.

"No, only the explosion incapacitated her, but she's getting better. Where are we leaving?" asked the Fist

"There's a back door nearby, but it's locked with a thick chain. I guess we'll have to blow them up." Eti said. Bina nodded,

apparently now taking charge.

They continued in the direction indicated until they reached the back exit. As they walked, she heard Grimmy purr softly.

"She's coming... I can feel her"

But no one seemed to notice

The good news was that the gates were open. Bad was that they were guarded by five aeon guards who turned to open fire on them. She was already aiming at them to incapacitate, or perhaps kill, one of them, but then a tall, fair-haired girl ran between the men, pierced one of the soldiers with a long blade and knocked down another with a powerful kick. Then the Smarty neutralized one, and Lilka with Itel took care of the other two... The woman stood in front of them smiling. She was tall and quite pretty, with long hair and deep blue eyes. She bowed courteously to them, raising her sword high, dripping blood.

"Lady Cala Grayskul at your service."she said in a melodious voice. Grimmy got up on her own.

"Hello Cala, Good to see you." the mystic said quietly. At that moment, Eti caught a smell, strange and irritating, nauseating.

What smells so bad? she thought.

She sensed her ward's arrival before she saw her. Sometimes it happened when she drew too much power, which after all came from their common patron ... She was not prepared for such a quick meeting. No… She wasn't prepared for Cala with Eti meet so soon. Her ward has certainly realized what she sees, she has squeezed too much information out of her, about her former life. But for now, she didn't say anything or show any sign that she saw what the other girl looked like.

"And you are that aristocrat! I have to admit you wasn't what I expected." Bina said.

" I have the impression that our wonderful Lady Cala will surprise us more than once during this trip." Dilayla murmured.

Just so you know she thought with bitter satisfaction.

Lilka, Alatar and Itel looked at the *aristocrat* with disbelief, and Eti winced at the sight of her.

"I'm glad I made such a good impression on you." Lady Cala bowed again. "But we're in a hurry. We must leave this place before the enemy gets reinforcements…" her voice was drowned out by the roar of the engines. The vehicle, a small spaceship, flew over the research facility. It hovered above them, and several rounds were fired from the turret into further buildings.

"Damn Azlanti space shuttle. If it's their support, we're in the shit. "Dilayla said

The side door swung open, and a tall woman slid down on her outstretched wings, her purple cloak billowing in the breeze.

"Hello, I'm Captain Moonshadow…" The winged woman introduced herself.

She felt her legs buckle under her. All strength and self-confidence flew away.

Impossible. you're dead

Moonshadow

Chapter Notes

20march i will update that chapter to italics

A few hours earlier, Captain Moonshadow and her First Officer Tonado had entered the headquarters of the Drejs, the largest gang on Saltmarsh. A dozen heavily armed Veskas stood up simultaneously and drew their weapons. She summoned a Solarian flare and smiled at them.

"Relax, I'm not going to fight anyone here. I'm here to talk to you. We are all beings who value honor. Anyone who knows me knows that I don't break my word.” she said, canceling the flare and adding in her mind. *Unless it's given to Azlanti worms*

"But if any of you so much as think of drawing a weapon, I'll chop them up into tiny little pieces!" Tonado threatened, glaring at the gang members. They smiled at Skittermander's threats, thinking they could effortlessly squash him like a bug. But they were wrong, and very much so, for her first mate was much more dangerous than they appeared and could easily have sliced several of them to pieces. She approached Veska, who was covered in ritual tattoos and wearing ornaments made of precious metals worth a small fortune.

„Hello Agnew. You've informed me that Grag is in possession of the person I'm looking for” she said, after first exchanging traditional Veskarian greetings.

"I didn't know Captain Moonshadow was into the slave trade." Agnew said.

„If this is the individual I am looking for, I will do everything to get him in my hands.” she clenched her metal prosthesis.

"If you say so… Grag wasn't going to sell it to you anyway. He had two buyers far more important than you, Captain. No offence." Veska said seriously looking at the interlocutor.

„I understand ..." she said barely controlling her anger. She was only the commander of a single cruiser, not a pirate queen…at least not yet. But revenge first „However, I would like to know the identity of my rivals."

Tonado stood by her side and crossed all six arms. He eyed Agnew menacingly.

„I don't know the identity of one of them... But the other is some Azlantean aristocrat... Nyseria Drakes?" Veska said. Captain Moonshadow gasped as hatred pulsed through her veins. So anyway... *It's going to be a race between us though... That's good... A few azlantis will know my grace* she tightened her prosthesis again until her fingers dug into the wood, but her left hand trembled with cold energy.

„I understand ... So I have no chance to beat them?" she asked, drawing the words slowly.

"So it's not you..." Agnew said, and the rest of her subordinates visibly relaxed.

„So i am not who?…" said the purple-haired woman coolly. Behind her mask, it was impossible to read what feelings tormented her heart, but everyone present knew that it is better not to annoy her now, otherwise a storm of blades and cold flames will unleash.

„Someone attacked Grag, some strange kids, apparently. We were wondering if you hired them." Veska said. Captain Moonshadow frowned.

„I wouldn't hire kids to do my job." she snapped sharply. Tonado moved closer to her, but she signaled him to be calm. For now.

"Neither would I expect you to be in the slave trade, and yet you do…" the woman said.

Veska was right. She hated the slave trade. She had freed many from the shackles of Azlanti slavery, but if this was an Invader… He had enslaved countless numbers, perhaps herself. She had no reason to show him pity.

„This is a private matter between Me and this individual. Where does this Grag live? I need to talk to him.” she said in a hard voice, she was very close…she can't lose her chance now.

„He is still under our protection.” Agnew said coolly. She looked at her. Don't worry, but the gang leader knew the threat behind those purple eyes. She considered all eventualities and added.

„On the other hand, after a failed auction, he will probably leave us anyway. You'll find it out of town... but you'd better head to the junkyard. Supposedly, Grag sold a droid owned by this alien there. Maybe he'll want it back.” Veska said

She nodded her head. "Junkyard you say…" she asked thoughtfully. "I'm going there. Thank you for the news. I won't trouble you any more. I'm going to a place I won't be back from anytime soon.” she said getting up from the table.

„So it's true! You're flying the Zone to escape the Azlanti!” Agnew exclaimed triumphantly. The captain looked at her coldly.

„ I never run away, especially from the minions of the eternal throne. I'm going there to find what belongs to me ...” she said going to the door.

„So what?” asked the leader of the Drejs.
„Revenge... Nothing else awaits me there.”

She didn't like the desert. Despite the mask, the dry and hot air hurt her damaged lungs and irritated her eyes. Fortunately, she

will not have to stay on this planet cursed by devils and demons. She doubted her crew would miss her… unless the stories told about this place turned out to be true. I remember so little. So much has been taken from me she thought with sadness, but then she hid her emotions. A pirate captain must not show weakness, he must be the personification of strength ... and terror. She looked at Shiren now, who clutched his maimed hand and trembled under her gaze. The two Damai glared at her defiantly, though they looked heavily battered. I think someone even broke his jaw. Vesk, who was still bandaged on a makeshift stretcher, was still seriously injured. He had a happy face painted on his bandage.

"I really don't know anything and I had no intention of selling sentient machines. It's all Grag's fault. He told me it was just a stupid toy. I swear by Hylax and Abadar. Please, don't lock me up in Long Death Cell. begged the insectoids.

„Do you know how i care about that junk? I'm interested in an individual of an unknown species... Tall and white-skinned, with bat ears. His eyes should be red and his hair blue…" she said slowly, and the insectoids nodded vigorously.

"He was, though his hair was rather motley and his eyes were pink… The bastard destroyed my sentinel robot, do you know how much I paid for it?! If you catch him, make him remember." He tried to gesticulate, but he waved his arm too hard and he screeched in pain.

If it's him, he'll wish he'd been born she thought with a faster heartbeat.

„Do you know where he went?" she asked, trying to keep her voice under control.

"Well, he and those kids took that droid… actually, he followed them himself. And then they came back and brought he here as if nothing had happened. They just left and waited for me to take

care of him?! You understand, Captain, they came, beat, robbed, and now they order me to heal! It ridicculou!” He gasped loudly.

"And you just said you wouldn't sell that droid if you knew it was self-aware." she shook her head. "You're doing something here, and I don't like cheaters as much as slave traders." She spoke very slowly without taking her eyes off Shiren. She wanted him to think carefully about his actions and the chosen way of life. She was a captive of the Azlanti, which is their de facto slave. She would never forget the hurt Star Empire had done to her. Whenever she could, she tried to free the slaves, despite the objections of some crew members. She looked at Tonado, who stood with all six sabers drawn, threatening all their enemies with violent death. *I set you free too, my brave little officer!* she thought tenderly and asked Vesk

„So you met them?”

The lizard groaned, but then spoke.

„Yes, but by chance. We were following a certain mercenary and her girlfriend, and then she started shooting at this guy, and we wanted to take the opportunity, but I guess the youngsters preferred to get rid of us first. Then they apologized and it turned out that the kids were looking for the observatory, and it turned out that I used to work there before everything went to hell, so I told them where to go in exchange for medical care and being taken to a safe place. As you can see, they fulfilled their bargain. He looked at her significantly. She ordered Tonado to give him the med-patch and asked where the observatory was. After receiving the answer, she was about to leave, but suddenly something occurred to her mind.

„ Actually, who hired you??” she asked carefully.

- A certain Azzzz…. He bit his tongue as he realized what he had said, but it was too late. She raised her hand and summoned a flare.

„Mercy… - said the wounded.

„But I'm merciless.” she said, and hurled the projectile at Vesk. Damai and Shiren jumped away from her as if they were going to be her next victim.

„Call my crew, there will be an unannounced battle. We'll collect some Azlantean heads.” she said firmly.

She was paralyzed with wonder… and horror. She had seen her, the woman who had died…who had sacrificed herself for them all. Including for her… even for her, though she'd never learned the whole truth about what she'd done to her. But she was standing in front of her. Queen Angela has risen from the dead. Has she come here to judge her? To finally get justice for all she's done?

"It's... nice to meet you and thank you for shooting those guys, but can we go now?" As you can see, Captain, we don't have a very good relationship with the Azlanti, just look at my crew and companions.” Bina said, smiling nervously and pointing at them. Lady Cala stood beside her, and asked.

„Who is this woman? You look like you've seen a ghost?” There is mild curiosity in her voice.

„It's her... Queen Angela.” she whispered hoarsely. Lady Cala raised an eyebrow.

„Queen Wingling? It's funny…although I can see you've had an interesting day even without it.” said the aristocrat, looking ostentatiously at the worried Wrongdak and Eti, who was wrinkling her nose with disgust.

Captain… Moonshadow looked at the woman with a bit of amusement. She wore a blue… glass diamond mask that covered the lower half of her face. She also lost her right arm, and her body was covered with Solarian symbols, but she retained her former majesty, which allowed her to lead the kingdom even after

so many tragedies. But this world, this immeasurable galaxy had also left its mark on her.

"I just want to talk to one of you… just for a moment." she said. Three passengers jumped off the ferry on ropes. Skittermander with blue fur, half-elf-half-drow and a huge Veska with one eye wielding a hammer of appropriate size. Arkan-tar winced at the sight of them. High above them, she saw the dark shape of a warship towering over the research facility.

She sighed but smiled to herself. Perhaps this would be a better solution... But she remembered her deal with Nyarlathotep and realized what a difficult choice she was facing. She looked at Lady Cala and asked her silently. The noblewoman nodded uncertainly, glancing at the ship. Adora could handle it, or at least try, she thought, but Angela's eyes didn't rest on her. And then she realized who she must be looking for here... She looked at the Wrongdak, who was a bit scared, but apparently completely unaware of the danger he was facing.

The captain walked over to the clone and spoke to him in a dangerously sweet voice.

"Look into my eyes..." she commanded and the stranger obeyed. The others guessed that the woman was interested in the species of their companion, but they did not even vaguely realize what they had in common... *This will be your last crime, Hordak* she thought bitterly.

- What's your name, my dear?” she asked, taking the clone with her mechanical hand under her chin.

"I'm Wrongdak, actually Wrong Hordak… are you going to harm my friends or mine, Captain?" There was fear and guilt in his voice this time.

„Wrong Hordak?” asked the winged pirate, confused, but the stranger smiled in response and said.

"That's what my friend called me when she mistook me for my brother... We all look the same because we are... we were clones of Horde Prime... but he has already been destroyed and we are all free." His voice was full of conviction and joy, as if the mere mention of the fact that he was already subservient to his elder made him happy, even in the face of such a threat. I envy him! she realized with amazement. On Angela's face, or at least the part she saw, there was surprise, consternation, and… disappointment.

„I understand ... at least partially. Go away, you are indeed free. she said, and looked at the others as if only now noticing them. "You're a strange band. Truly extraordinary. Where and for what purpose are you going ...” she asked and looked at the massive shield of the observatory. “It's an impressive building. It was created to observe a place in the galaxy that even Besmara herself would fear. If such an unusual company gathers on such a sloppy planet, there is only one reason.” She leaned over and looked up at the starry sky. "There's a certain place there..." Her voice was dreamy at the moment and full of poetic delight. “Full of wonders and ancient mysteries. They call it Etheria, and that's where I'm going…” she paused and added in a much harder voice. „To gain riches we have never dreamed of... „ she looked at her companions. She noticed that Arkan-tar was examining the tips of his boots very carefully, and Veska and the elven-drow half-breed were looking at him as if they wanted to do something very painful to him. "Unfortunately, for all their undoubted advantages, my crew lacks the knowledge necessary to meet the challenges we face, besides ... Well, we may need people with a little more diplomatic skills. She looked at Lady Cala, who smiled kindly at her. "You're an aristocrat from a rich family… They said at the port that one of these arrived at the port today." I understand it's you. You can be of use to us. - she said. *You are a woman who by sheer force of will united the entire planet against a common enemy, and you ask for help from the most inhuman creature you have ever met in your life* she wanted to scream.

„And I can make broth there, if anything.” Eti unexpectedly broke into the conversation and pulled out a very tired carcass of some

bird from the bag. And now she realized that Angela was now facing quasi Catra. *Have they ever met? Catra kidnapped Glimmer and I actually tortured her, this girl doesn't know what she's risking.* She thought in horror. Zraz will lose his chance, his chance at redemption. He has to do something. Ignoring the warning look of her ward, she stepped forward.

"I am a sorceress of great power and a person of many other talents." she said, fully aware that this was how she signed her own sentence. The captain couldn't recognize her face, but she certainly remembered her voice. But she didn't care what happened to her. Captain Moonshadow… Angela looked at her in surprise.

„That's interesting... We could use a talented mystic... What are your other talents?" she asked, looking at her with a raised eyebrow.

Torturing children, condemning royal consorts to a fate worse than death, manipulating queens to do may will. she wanted to scream in her face.

„I know about management... Or gardening." she said instead in a quiet, shy voice, not understanding what was going on. According to their agreement with Nyarlathotep, she forbade her from revealing her identity directly to the people of Etheria, but it wasn't her fault if they accidentally recognized her. Moonshadow laughed.

„I'm a gardener too. On Jadehell, I learned a lot more about the vegetation there than I would have liked. Have you heard of my gardens of the long death? Oh, maybe you'll see them… though not as their guest… unless you betray me…" The captain said and laughed. She realized she had never heard Queen Angela laugh. They knew each other for a short time, but there was so much venom and anger in that laugh...

„I also know about similar matters." she said bitterly and chuckled. „Exceedingly good." she said. She saw that Rechiza and

Arkan-tar exchanged knowing glances. Meanwhile, two more pirates came out of the ferry. All but Skittermander began looting the dead Azlanti. Two turned out to be alive, so they tied them up.

„Back to the broth issue.” Eti interjected. „I can cook ... - She did not finish, because the green-haired Elf interrupted her.

„My friend has a rather strange sense of humor and she was a little stressed today.” she tried to pull Eti away from the captain.

„I have no sense of humor ... not in the least, and I stress others. Would you please not mislead the Captain. As for the broth…” the cat girl replied, but Bina interrupted her

„Give me a break with this broth!” There was a pleading note in her voice.

„Both tradition and science confirm that chicken soup is great for colds because...”

This time it was the dragonkin who intervened.

„Eti, this bird is in such a state that it will crawl out of the pot on its own.

„What? You want to poison the Captain!” Skittermander threatened

Moonshadow laughed, much warmer this time, and signaled her furry subordinate to calm down.

„You remind me of someone... Someone from my past.” She heard sadness in her voice.

Your daughter... and her friends. Remember… she said in her mind.

They heard a roar, and an armored personnel carrier belonging to Bina and her charges drove in. There were traces of blood on the hood.

"Calm down, guys, it's all right." No need to fight. Bina reassured him as the pirates aimed their weapons at the vehicle.

„There were some weird ones with guns and they're gone now, but the droid still works.” she heard sadness in the hoarse voice of the machine.

„Unfortunately, victory is never absolute and you will always believe that you can do more.” Eti said in the tone of a lecturer.

You are right, girl she thought bitterly. Then Lady Cala walked past her. She approached Captain Moonshadow, ignoring Skittermander's protests. In one graceful movement, she drew her epee, and before anyone could react, she knelt down and called out.

"If you truly swear to protect us, if you protect my comrades... Then I swear by the ancient Motto of our lineage that I will assist in your mission, whatever it may be." She touched Angela's feet with the blade...

You don't want to ... do it, let it be what must be.

"I swear for honor of Grayskull that I will fulfill our half of the bargain!" she shouted. Dilayla snorted contemptuously, Itel and Eti giggled… Bina rolled her eyes. Only Wrongdak looked at her with pure admiration. Poor fool, you are looking at a being more vile and inhuman than your Big Brother, only kept on a short leash by a far greater power Her own blood was roaring in her ears. She knew that Angela would recognize this call, which after all changed the fate of all Etheri. Across the galaxy. He must remember that...

Captain Moonshadow snorted and laughed briefly.

„The ancestors were pirates, necromancers or just drank from the skulls of slain enemies?” Angela asked.

Lady Cala stood up and said with a cheerful, warm and absolutely false smile.

„The founder of our family was Mara, and apparently that was her motto. It's a long story and we'll talk about it another time. Now the evening flight of flies is approaching and we'd better hide in the vehicles.

She watched the whole scene in disbelief. She did not understand why Angela did not recognize the call that Adora had shouted in front of her. She didn't know the truth about what the First Ones had done to Etheria and what the sword really was, but the name Grayskull should have moved her, and she had only made a few derisive remarks. Lady Cala turned to her, and for a moment that beautiful, flawless face spread such a sadistically triumphant smile that she feel nauseated However, Captain Moonshadow did not see this. She nodded and said

„Excellent. We're leaving tomorrow night, so I hope you're ready. In space, we will discuss the flight path in more detail ... Now we really don't have time.

Arkan-tar approached Lady Cala as she passed by.

„I think the decision to work with someone like that ...” he wanted to say, but her ward gently but firmly pushed him away and stood next to her

"I have a feeling we're about to have an interesting family reunion." Cala said softly, cheerfully

Rosie blinked twice at Lady Cala's smile at Miss Daisy. He was… Inappropriate, as if they were sharing some terrible secret together now. She didn't know the two women well, but they seemed quite nice. Lady Cala was a strong, beautiful, and intelligent aristocrat, something a girl like Rosie always wanted to be, though she knew she couldn't. Miss Daisy was a wise and powerful, if somewhat dark, sorceress. She didn't understand what it was all about. And she had the impression that Miss Daisy knew Captain Moonshadow. Maybe she just imagined it? She had

better eyesight than most and usually saw what others couldn't. Only sometimes she was a bit… inexperienced. She didn't understand the nuances and complications of the complexity of social relationships, so maybe that was the case this time too? But she met a real space pirate, and she was as scary as the stories said. She really shouldn't be happy about this, but she felt so excited.

She and the rest got into this funny transporter. Inside, Emily was waiting for them, and she approached Wrongdak and complained to him in her own language. She stood in the center of the room, unsure of whom she should sit with, but then Eti waved to her and showed that there was room between her and the itel. At first she was hesitant, because she got the impression that the elf didn't like her, but the elf nodded as if a bit thoughtful, so she sat down with the whole pack. Opposite them sat Miss Daisy and Lady Cala. Next to Eti, she saw Lilka, who was sitting hunched over, and Alatar was in the last place, slightly squeezed. She looked away so that no one would think she was staring at the red-haired girl, but it seemed so strange to her that the previously fearless warrior now seemed terrified. Eti must have noticed, because she turned to Rosie.

-„Lilka is afraid of insects... and now clouds of flies are about to come.” Eti explained. She seemed dejected, as if the sudden rush of adrenaline drained her strength.

- Does it have to do with Swarm? Your planet was attacked by Swarm?, right?” she asked, hoping she wouldn't come off as nosy. "They're from Kesler, and the Swarm didn't attack it, just devoured it, but you're roughly right." said the feline in such a way that she gave the impression that she was talking about the weather. Rosie's eyes widened and she looked at Itel.

"I'm sorry... I didn't know..." she said feeling guilty.
"Are you part of the Swarm or related to it in any way?" Itel asked

with a sour smile. Rosie shook her head, and the elf laughed, though there was no mirth in her eyes, then added.

„When our planet was being destroyed, we fled to Atrax. The Shadows of Tarak helped us... If not for them... We found Eti on Atrax. Bina looked after us when we left for Akiton. And now here we are… Itel said, staring thoughtfully into space.

„But why are you here? I don't mean to be nosy, but the Zone is not a place anyone would want to fly because it's... scary.

Itel wanted to say something, most likely to keep Rosie out of her business, but Eti interjected.

„For a whatsit… A friend of a friend is looking for a whatsit to be able to heal himself. This will give Itel a lot of whatsits. Only this whole Etheria is a planet full of whatsits, so it takes someone smart to tell one whatsit from another. But it all comes down to the whatsits."

It all comes down to whatsits, she repeated the words of the girl so similar to Catra in her mind and giggled to herself. *Yes, this is the most accurate summary of all these decades of warfare. It was all about the whatsits. Whatsits built by Hordak. Whatsit. which Adora found in the forest. A Whatsit built by Entrapta that nearly erased us from reality. The Whatsit into which our entire planet has been turned against our will. We fought, we killed and... we gave our lives for whatsits we didn't even understand. After all, we are all just whatsits in the hands of beings older and more powerful than us* she thought and looked at her ward, who was watching her new companions with lazy interest. "Even you my dear...Even you," she smiled sourly to herself. The noise slowly grew stronger. The transporter slowed down because visibility was probably poor. The red-haired girl cringed. Eti looked at her as if she thought for a moment what she should do, then hugged her, as if only now realizing that sentient beings do this. Who are you. Who made you like this. Have you met another me in your life?

she thought as she looked at her. Lady Cala got up and walked over to the group of friends and Rosie, who apparently decided to befriend them.

„Hello. As you remember, I am Lady Cala Grayskull. I am very happy that I will be traveling in the company of such a competent and well-coordinated team.” she said smiling cheerfully and radiantly. As always. Itel smiled proudly, but also with great self-confidence, Dragonkin lowered his eyes, embarrassed, the red-haired girl... Lilka paid no attention to it, but Eti... suddenly got up and started sniffing the aristocrat. Then she pushed it violently.

„I was wondering what it smelled like! It's you! I do not like you! From now on you will be called Reeka!” she called so loudly that all the passengers in the vehicle heard her. Lady Cale looked at her sadly.

„It's not nice to make fun of someone's disability. My body emits an unpleasant odor. I take medication to reduce it, though I can see it's not effective on people with a keen sense of smell like you.”

Rosie, Itel and Bina looked at Eti disapprovingly, but the girl paid no attention. She crossed her arms over her chest and scowled at Lady Cala.

After a while, the aristocrat returned to her. The noise was strong enough that most passengers wouldn't hear it anyway, and they put their headphones in their ears.

„You'll have to increase the doses when we get to Etheria. If Eti sensed you, Catra probably sensed you, too, and that could ruin all our plans. Do you remember our agreement?” Sharply asked.

„Oh, I remember your deal very well. I understand that this rude one-armed wench also includes.”

She didn't bother to answer her ward, just nodded and asked.

"When you swore before Captain Moonshadow... What would you do if she recognized the call?"

Lady Cala shrugged.

„Same as when she recognized you. Well… Glimmer was used to being a half-orphan.” She smiled cheerfully at her.

I forgot that I am neither the only nor even the greatest monster on this planet

In the pale starlight

They stopped in front of the hotel, arousing noticeable terror of the security guards. The flies had passed and the sky was clear. The air was cold, filled with the smell of salt and baked food. At this hour, after passing by of flies, the city was coming back to life again, this time more mysterious and vicious… Dilayla squeezed outside, dragging Rosie with her, who said goodbye to their new friends. The prettiest of the beauties came out with her "babysitter", who now seemed to have aged at least ten years, stood behind them. Cala was so radiant that she was about to glow, and Miss Daisy seemed to be in an even grimmer mood. Well, given her experience in life, she sympathized much more with genuinely gloomy people than with falsely cheerful ones. Arkan-tar and Rechiza stood beside her, clearly waiting for an opportunity to discuss the events of the long day. Wrongdak seemed very tired and a bit confused, but he seemed happy.

It's a really naive and good-natured creature. And it went to people like us. Rosie glanced over, yawning very tired after such an intense day. *You too are a kind-hearted creature who found herself in a place where she shouldn't be, among people who have done some nasty things in their lives* she thought and glanced at the dark sorceress. *Or Much More Than A Few*

„Well, today we will prepare everything for you, and you will sleep and pack, do shopping or go to the spa, because after that we will spend the next few months in space away from anything, so there will be no opportunity for such things.” Bina declared and climbed into her insane transporter.

"Well, we need to notify Dr. Quin, pack up again that day, and hit the road tomorrow." Arkan-tar said and stretched. Rosie let out that weird moan of hers.

„Do we really have to take her with us? She is rude and treat me like mule!” asked the deaf girl.

"We have orders to take her, and she's a seasoned scientist." Arkan-tar said spreading his hands in a gesture of helplessness. Dilayla patted Rosie on the back.

"Don't worry, I'll protect you from that mean rat."

The girl nodded and together they entered the apartment. Dr. Quin, who had been watching a soap opera from fifty years ago, turned to them.

„Where have you been! I'm sitting here by myself, taking care of our equipment, watching over everything, and what? You're taking my only intern!" she said loudly and ran over to Rosie. "And you get to work!" I'm not paying you to wander around town and slack off!"

„You don't pay me at all! The government does it, and I haven't seen the money anyway, I probably won't!" The gloves were very loud now. Dilayla put her hand on the shoulder of the girl who was red with anger.

„Take it easy, young one, if this rat is going to fire you, I can afford to hire you to take care of my equipment. I'm guessing Arkan-tar, Rechiza and Miss Daisy will also contribute in return for your help?" she didn't want to suggest Lady Cala, because otherwise the girl would really end up as the aristocratic equivalent of a sleeping bag friend. Hearing her words, Arkan-tar adjusted his glasses coughing, Rechiza nodded, and Miss Daisy looked at her as if aroused from her thoughts.

"Yes, I will gladly support Rosie. She is a gifted and talented girl and I will definitely find a more suitable activity for her than carrying equipment that we will probably have no use for…. said the grim elf. Dilayla raised an eyebrow. She knew that the sorceress had a soft spot for the deaf girl, although unlike the hotheaded elf, she didn't think that she liked younger girls... though her reaction to the strange Pahtra was puzzling, it could have been sorcerers' quirk, they have a weakness for cats. Qin narrowed her only organic, and the metal gleamed ominously, and

Miss Daisy smiled at her and snapped her fingers several times. Ysoka turned and then saw Wrongdak, who was reaching for caked hard candies. His strange droid was standing next to him.

"Hello, I'm Wrongdak, actually..." He didn't finish as Dr. Qin smiled at him and slapped his knee.

" I'm Dr. Qin... You're a very interesting creature... I've never seen anything like this! What are you?" she watched him as a fascinating phenomenon.

„This is not creature! This is a person!” Rosie screamed in anger, but the scientist ignored her.

“I am a clone, a clone of Horde Prime from the Galactic Horde. But now I'm free…" Wrongdak said patiently. Dilayla had the impression that she felt calm in the company of the scientist. It was probably the first slightly disturbing thing he'd done. However, he said that his friend was a very smart woman ... Maybe she was also a scientist?

Dr. Qin waved her hand as if she considered what he was saying to be completely unimportant…

„ Yes, yes, it's very interesting. But I'm asking about the species! About what you are!” She tugged at his knees, excited but also annoyed. Wrongdak looked at her surprised and said slowly.

"We were never told that... we were just his brothers... little brothers... but he treated us like things... our only value was that we were his clones, poor copies of him." He sat down sadly. The droid came up to him and started rubbing against him. But Ysoka screamed loudly.

"Oh... Paldus Vagus, that's what your species will be called... I'll be famous for discovering and describing the first specimen of the White Demon, and this is only the beginning of the journey. she rubbed her hands. Dilayla thought it would be funny if the Order of the Eclipse would admit who attacked her planet and reveal what it knew about the Wrongdak species, the doctor might break

down. She would love to be there. Wongdak sank into the armchair exhausted, and Rosie yawned and rubbed her eyes. Dilayla felt tired too. It had been a long day and full of unusual, unexpected events. Two of them have shaken her enough that she has to rethink who she should be loyal to and who a true friend is, and who's the enemy...

"Why don't we go up to the roof and discuss today's events? Meanwhile, Miss Rosie and Mr. Wrongdak will freshen up.” Lady Cala said suddenly. Everyone nodded their heads in agreement.

„Keep an eye on him from Qin, because she will dissect him when he go sleep.” She patted the deaf girl on the shoulder. Rosie saluted and giggled, which also sounded a bit odd. Then they went to the roof of the hotel, escorted by the disapproving looks of the staff. A cold wind blew overhead, and the pale stars shone coldly above their heads. When she was sure they were alone, she placed an armored hand on Arkan-tar's shoulder, squeezing it meaningfully.

„I have only one question for you. Who the hell is Dr. Sidonius and what is his connection to my sister! And don't you son of a bitch try to lie to me or I'll rip your hands off.” she growled. Arkan-tar looked at the others, but they also wanted to know the answer to this question, so they were not going to intervene in his defense.

„Your sister?” he asked, obviously confused. At least in this regard, he seemed to have nothing to hide.

"The woman who spoke on the recording at the observatory. She was seriously… very seriously injured when Wrongdak’s Big Brother attacked my home planet and much of her body had to be replaced with cybernetic implants. I left her with the Order of the Eclipse but… she ended up aboard that damn Galleon, I don't know how.” she explained. She felt ashamed of actually abandoning her sister, but it made her feel even angrier.

The scientist swallowed and began to talk.

"He's a very old vampire…" she clenched her fist tighter, so he added. „But really very old, remembering the times of the Lost Golarion. He… I know he's been researching what happened during the Gap… quite obsessively, if you ask me. He's been dead for a very long time and is fascinated by the First Ones. Supposedly, he thinks they have to do with the break and memory loss for all of us. He is said to be one of the few people who know the language of this ancient race.„ Verthani explained.

„Really? I've only heard of one person who could speak the language of the First ones and it wasn't a damed hiding in shadows parasite.” Miss Daisy said contemptuously and giggled. There was something really wrong with this woman...

„It's a fact ... he's not the only one anyway.” Rechiza tapped one of her metal eyes „He made my eyes ... after my accident. „ she shuddered and added. “I could read the writing on that feline girl's hand.

"Eti's hand is a First Ones artifact?" exclaimed Miss Daisy, genuinely surprised. At the mention of the girl's name, Lady Cala winced. "Oh someone's jealous of mommy's attention!" thought Dilayla, smiling maliciously.

„Yes, the writing said "Here is the Punishing Hand which has been created to..." and here the signs ends. I have no idea where she got such an artifact, but it probably doesn't matter. We are far from Abbalon and are unlikely to encounter any ruins of this ancient race. Lashunti” said with a shrug.

"Oh, it's not that simple…" Lady Cala interjected. Everyone looked at her.

Rechiza turned to Lady Caly. The beautiful aristocrat had been silent at the beginning of the discussion, but now she clearly had something very important, perhaps shocking, to announce.

“Mara, the woman I mentioned, was one of the First Ones.”

That was shocking thought the witchwarper. There was silence, only a cold wind howling between the buildings. It was news she wasn't prepared for. Their companion is a descendant of an extremely mysterious and ancient race, those who left behind abandoned cities on Abbalon ... and monsters, like the one that made her lose her antennae and eyes. She looked at Miss Daisy. "Is that why you found this girl? Because of her origin? Like a parasite, you clung to a young woman to gain access to dark secrets… Dilayla broke the silence.

„Or maybe you still have an angel in your lineage or maybe some god right away? It is an enduring fashion among aristocrats.” The blue-haired mercenary smiled. Rechiza had no idea why this woman was so mean, but her remark was not only insulting, but completely inappropriate.

"I'm sorry, but as I understand it, this Mara, even if she really was one of the First Ones., after all these countless centuries, the blood is absolutely diluted, unless you practice inbreeding, as is sometimes said of the Azlanti." He smiled with a bit of superiority.

"I never claimed that my blood made me better than others in any way, though some genes might have survived. But think about the implications of this fact...” said the noblewoman looking seriously at the three of them, while Miss Daisy stood thoughtful.

Rechiza was the first to understand.

„Etheria was the planet of the First Ones.” she said. Arkan-tar whistled in appreciation, but Dilayla yawned. Lady Cala nodded and said.

“It was their colony, or rather a research center. It is full of precious and ancient artifacts, sometimes extremely valuable or powerful.”

"And we're going there with one of the craziest pirates in the galaxy..." Arkan-tar said. Miss Daisy gave him a murderous look. Her earlier reaction to Captain Moonshadow was surprising, could

the disfigured sorceress also once be a pirate? That would explain a lot.

„Yes, but there will be enough treasures and artifacts for everyone ... anyway, we only want to deactivate or annihilate the weapons that threatened the galaxy. Of course, we have to be careful not to let it fall into the hands of Captain Moonshadow, but we shouldn't have a problem with that, because we have the support of the Lord Admiral's armada. However, the biggest reward will be something completely different. On Etheria, we may find a way to the home world of the First Ones, Eternia.

It sounded even beter. If they managed to find their way to the home world of one of the most powerful races in known galactic history… Even if the First Ones died out, the potential was mind-blowing. Arkan-tar folded his fingers into a pyramid and smiled with greedy bliss.

"I guess that explains why the doctor is so interested in this place, but we still don't know what connection he has with Captain Blazebringer. These kids seem to know both, judging by their reaction to the broadcast.” said Verthani, staring at the stars.

"I'm incredibly interested in extinct ancient species, it's normally my fucking hobby... But now will someone tell me who Captain Blazebringer is? Anyone know his identity?” asked the mercenary. Arkan'tar rubbed his jaw thoughtfully.

„Nobody knows anything for sure about him. Even his original species is unknown, only that he has undergone significant cybernetic modifications and is currently hardly considered a biological being. He lives quite a long time and has traveled all known worlds, and he was also supposedly in the farthest corners of the galaxy. He has the opinion of a pridefull, ruthless and calculating person. Supposedly, although we already know it's true, he came into possession of the "Dreams of Eternity" Void Galleon, which is a mystery in itself.” said Verthani with commitment. *This one likes to listen to his own voice*, thought Rechiza.

"Void Galleon? And what the hell is that. I've never heard of such ships. Does my sister really have access to such an arsenal.” asked the mercenary, radiating distrust.

„There is nothing strange about your lack of knowledge. These are the ships that were built during the Gap. At the same time, their construction began in different places in the galaxy, but all the ships were identical. At least at first. They had a strange silent AI and the ability to assimilate the technology they encountered. However, a drift drive was never installed on them. A hundred years after the end of the Gap, they've all been destroyed... Except for the last one. "Dreams of Eternity" is a legend in itself, not to mention its captain. As for the weapons... Captain Blazebringer is said to have come into possession of some ancient arsenal, but I don't know how true that is.” he threw up his arms. The mercenary wasn't happy with his answers, but apparently she had to make do with them, because she wouldn't get any others.

„The matter of vampires and mysterious ships is settled. Lady Cala took over the discussion. "Do we need to talk about our new captain?"

„What about her? She has a somewhat uncouth and very young but surprisingly knowledgeable crew. I can't say too much bad about her, have you noticed anything disturbing about her? You know her less than we do, but we know her only half a day.” Lashunti said. Suddenly, Arkan-tar spoke up.

"She's fine, except she looks like Lady Ka, the Lord Admiral's Left Hand, as she likes to call herself."

„Are they very similar?” Rechiza asked surprised. Bina was the last woman she would suspect of being connected to someone like the Lord Admiral.

„They're identical. Almost, because they lead a decidedly different lifestyle.” Arkan-tar said Miss Daisy looked at him surprised.

"Twin sisters or clones?" Rechiza asked the scholar.

"I don't know, but I think it's best if they don't find out about each other." Verthani said.

"Back to the clone issue..." Dilayla interjected. “Our new companiom Wrongdak is one of them, which I can confirm both from my own memories and from what I learned from the knights of the order. More importantly, his master, Horde Prime, The creator of the ravaged zone and its undivided ruler has been destroyed.

It shocked her too. The Order could barely manage with a small scouting force, thanks to the summons of their infernal allies. The one who was able to defeat him...

„Well, not only will we not encounter The swarm, but the white demons will not be a threat to us either. This trip is starting to look more and more like a summer walk.” Arkan-tar said, smiling with relief.

„It won't be that easy.” Dilayla said and showed them a strange coin and told them about her meeting with a Shiren miner. To her, it looked pretty ordinary, though the words "United we will cast out shadows" sounded defiant, but it wasn't unusual. Miss Daisy and Lady Cala examined the coin carefully. She had the impression that the dark sorceress smiled crookedly at the sight of the coin and sighed as if with resignation. That was interesting too. Arkan-tar looked at the coin and laughed briefly.

"It's quite funny ... Did you know that I saw such a sign? On the other side of the galaxy, on the planet Ashenzee, but life there was destroyed thousands of years ago."

This time they all looked at him with a silent question. The scholar shrugged with feigned modesty.

"I took part in an archaeological expedition. We studied the remains of a long-extinct civilization there. They were small bat-like creatures. They had rudimentary wings that disappeared in the process of evolution. They were descendants of night

creatures, and in their culture this sun was the personification of evil and hatred... They were to lose their wings as a result of a contract with this "Demon", in exchange for protection against his hateful rays. They developed normally, until a group decided to reject traditional beliefs and flew into space, although it was forbidden. Soon after, there was a regression of civilization among those who remained on Ashenzee. After several hundred years, their rebellious brothers returned, but they were changed. Taller and fitter, but above all, winged. They overthrew old beliefs and subjugated their less developed relatives. They were worshiped like gods, and this symbol, the bat's wings, became their symbol. They called themselves Sun Slayer. said Verthani with the skill of a professor.

"And what happened to those 'Sun Slayers'?" asked Miss Daisy.

„What always happens to the proud and the arrogant. They fell and only ashes remained." Arkan-tar said smiling ironically.

You've been ran from justicee Horde Prime for a long time, but it's caught up with you anyway. Now I know your great secret, or at least part of it... Though Sun Slayers was a much more... poetic name, you should admit it yourself, she thought as she looked at the coin. She also ordered the money to be minted, for many reasons, though Hordak never quite understood why she did it. *But I wasn't cheating on the bullion. The loss of reputation wasn't worth the small savings.* she thought. But this coin showed that something of Prime's empire had survived. It didn't surprise her, the spies of Creeping Chaos had heard rumors that the situation in the Ravaged Zone was complicated, but still she felt... disappointed. She hoped that after so many years of war, the people of Etheria would find peace. *At least until you return, my dear Shadow Weaver.*

„It's fascinating. I feel surrounded by extinct civilizations. You may have some more up your sleeve. the halfelf asked in an annoyed tone. S*he pretends to be a simple bully, but this woman is very smart. She is better aware of what is going on around them than an educated archaeologist and witchwarper. She doesn't trust*

Lady Caly, which in itself is a sign of great shrewdness, since all of Carurystal has fallen for this masquerade."

I think two will be enough for us. However, we must determine what we are telling the Lord Admiral. Arkan-tar said, massaging his temple. He smiled slyly.

„We must surely inform him that neither the Swarm nor the whole Horde are waiting for him there, at least not in full force.” Rechiza said, looking hard at the others.

"It's rather unavoidable, because and yet his fleet may be needed." Lady Cala said thoughtfully. *Only to whom and for what? Are you already planning something?* she thought, watching as her ward effortlessly takes control of their small group.

"But I see no reason to tell him what Etheria was, at least for now." He'd be sick of the job of bringing order to the ruins of an empire anyway. We'll tell him everything, in the right way, when we need his fleet's help. continued the aristocrat. Everyone nodded, agreeing to her proposal, though the mercenary didn't look convinced.

"And what shall we tell him about our new captain and her crew?" Rechiza asked.

That's the problem... This woman looks identical to one of the Lord Admiral's subordinates, and somehow I doubt they're twins. And with her is a girl so similar to Catra. It's not a coincidence.

'I don't see the slightest reason to bother the Lord Admiral with this. Likewise, we don't tell our new associates anything, including Wrongdak. Ignorance is bliss, at least sometimes. *I need time to discover the truth. And I have so little of it.*

It seemed to her that everyone agreed with what she said, although Dilayla smiled mysteriously. “I have to keep an eye on this woman, she might get in our way.

„Is that all?" Arkan-tar asked. „We hold our tongues until the situation is fully clarified.” he was about to go to their room to rest like the rest, but she decided to ask him one more question.

„Captain Moonshadow... Who is she?” She stared hard at the scholar, wanting to make sure he wasn't fooling her. Verthani thought, as if trying to remember what he knew about the woman.

"It's not my favorite subject of study, but I know quite a bit about pirates. Captain Moonshadow is one of the most dangerous. She was first heard of when she launched a rebellion on the Azlanti prison planet of Jadehell. It's a scary place full of poisonous plants. They poison the air there, but not enough to kill you right away. He does it slowly, day by day. It damages the lungs and eyes. And the Azlanti don't provide adequate protection. Plus, fungus spores can enter the brain through the eyes… Life expectancy there is six months, and she was there ten months, but came out in acceptable health. She has to wear a mask to help her breathe, and her wings have also been damaged, so she has to cybernetically assist them. I don't know what happened to her hand. It has a cruiser that we've already seen. His name is Merciless. The name fits very well with the character of the captain herself. She ruthlessly fights the Azlanti. He hunts their ships and loots their outposts. He does not harm the helpless, but he knows no mercy when the soldiers of the Star Empire are involved. It is said that he has several cell on his cruiser where he grows Jadehell plants. All the officers go there and die slowly. She mentioned them to you… They're called the Gardens of the Long Death.” He looked at her as if expecting praise.

She wanted to laugh. She couldn't stop herself. It was all so… unfair. She, the woman who ruined the lives of so many. Shadow Weaver, who has worked so hard to be hated by everyone she knows, has spent the last five years in luxury. She was widely estimated, arousing respect and even sympathy from those who knew how disfigured she had been. And Angela, the woman who suffered so much, who sacrificed her life to save them all, ended

up a pirate. She became a ruthless and cruel woman whose soul burned with a thirst for revenge. She has received so much grace that she does not remember who she is. But she would return to Etheria, and she would have to confront what she was with what she had become. *Oh, you don't lock prisoners in a spare bedroom anymore. You show them a lot more respect*. And she burst out laughing, a loud uncontrollable laugh that was devoid of joy. Tears ran down her face. The others looked away from her in embarrassment, except for Lady Caly, who looked at her with undisguised contempt. But now she didn't care. It was just too much for one day. She stood up and, with difficulty, refrained from laughing and crying, she said in a broken voice.
"I'm sorry, it's just that life just seemed so…comically unfair to me, don't you think?"

Rosie couldn't sleep. The experiences of that day were comming back to her as soon as she closed her eyes. She wasn't used to fighting gunfights. To someone wants to hurt her. Nor to meet other people, so unusual. She tossed and turned in bed, unable to calm down. She woke up in a cold sweat, so she finally decided to get up, knowing she wouldn't be able to sleep again. In her room, Dr. Quin slept snoring loudly. Wrongdak took a sofa too small for him, but it didn't seem to bother him, because he slept the sleep of the righteous. Lady Cala lay on the bed like a bas-relief on a tomb, beautiful but almost too perfect, almost unreal. Miss Daisy was asleep at the desk, above the datapad for retirees. She smelled of some sweet alcohol. She was curious about it. On the datapad screen, she saw the hand of a woman holding a plant. The hand was troughed with numerous calluses, like a warrior's. The person it belonged to must have spent a lot of time training with weapons... It certainly didn't belong to Lady Caly, for her hands were graceful and delicate, although she had seen with her own eyes what an excellent swordsman she was. In the background she could see some cavernous swamps.

„Glmh. wht yu to”. The gray-skinned elf said indistinctly, opening her eyes. She blinked a few times and shook her head.

„Ah, it's you Rosie... I took you for someone from my past... What are you doing here? You can not sleep?” she asked. She was sleepy, but regained consciousness quickly.

„No ... It's like this ... I wasn't peeping ... I just can't sleep, so I decided to pass „ she felt herself blushing. Miss Daisy looked at the Datapad and smiled sourly.

"I guess I'm getting old... I used to guard my secrets much more carefully..." she said and turned off the datapad.

„You couldn't sleep either?” Rosie asked the older woman, who sighed.

My body hardly needs sleep or food anymore... But sometimes my mind needs to sleep... but it's already rested... Want to get some air?” she asked her. Rosie was surprised by the request, but after a moment's thought she nodded her agreement.

Miss Daisy led her to the roof, from where they could admire the panorama of the city, or rather, several nearby rooftops. Not a very picturesque view. But when she looked up, she saw a clear night sky and felt it take her breath away. She had never seen him with her own eyes, she was sure of it, though she remembered so little. She felt as if she could see the whole universe, all its mysteries and secrets. You just need to focus your eyes a bit more. She felt so small, like an insignificant bug standing in front of a colossus, unimaginably beautiful, but at the same time completely indifferent to her existence. It should have terrified her, but somehow it soothed her. The awareness of her own fragility in the face of this immensity was liberating, she felt that no one was imposing on her the path she should follow.

„What do you see in them? In these stars.” said Miss Daisy, as if she were talking about something disgusting. She was sitting on the edge of the roof, her legs dangling out. She had a bottle of Brandy in her hand. Rosie sat next to her. The height didn't scare her.

„You don't like stars? I thought all the elves loved them.” she asked surprised.

The grey-skinned woman smiled and took a long swig from the bottle.

„As you can see, not all of them. Besides, I haven't seen them for most of my life, and even then, on Carurystal, I rarely had the opportunity to see them. You understand because of the clouds. „she said, and then her face kind of flickered a bit.

"Your face... something is going on... is it supposed to be like this?" she asked scared.

You have good eyesight”, Rosie. said the sorceress and reached behind the nape of her neck. Then the holographic mask disappeared and she saw her true face. It was covered with wide scars, as if someone had broken porcelain. Her hair was jet black and her eyes were yellow with vertical pupils. Her lip was torn on one side and a sharp fang protruded from it. The hands ended in long, sharp claws. She covered her mouth at the sight and stepped back, but then came back. *I shouldn't act like this. I shouldn't judge others by their appearance*.

„Are you not afraid of me? I don't disgusting you?” Miss Daisy asked and took another sip from the bottle.

„A bit ... - admitted the girl with shame. „But it's not your fault ... How we look doesn't determine who we are ...”

Miss Daisy looked away from her and gave a hoarse laugh.

„Twice you're wrong girl... At least in my case. This is all my fault, the price I paid for the choice I made. However, its consequences have affected countless people ...” she drank again from the bottle. The sorceress stared thoughtfully into space. She seemed so gloomy and depressed now, more so than usual.

"Did it hurt…?" she asked, and immediately feared she was being too nosy. Miss Daisy looked at her in astonishment.

„Did it hurt... Heh, no one asked me that question. Yes, it hurt a lot. I spent decades experiencing constant agony… but also euphoria. A power beyond comprehension flowed through my veins. It gave me strength and made me powerful. But right after that she was running away from me like by a sieve with holes in it.”

„ But how did it happen ... Did someone hurt you? she asked not sure what she should think about what the grim elf told her.

„Yes... Someone hurt me.” Miss Daisy began to speak, she seemed animated. „Myself.” she glanced at the astonished Rosie. “You see, I used to be a teacher at a magic school, a real magic school that educated students from all over the world where I was born. I was a very capable and strong sorceress, whose wisdom was widely appreciated by all. I have trained many skilled sorcerers, but one of them was special. I had never seen anyone so powerful before, and then only one person… I was proud to be his mentor, but part of me envied his power… But it was a trying time for all of us. Because a great evil… No, let's just call it a mighty adversary, has hit our world. Few could stand up to them. I tried to convince other sorcerers to support the war effort, but they were skeptical, they valued our neutrality so much. But I worked hard to devise a way to defeat the enemy. I found a ritual, ancient and forbidden. It summoned a powerful, terrifying being that gave great power, but could turn the user into a dark being… a magic-eating parasite. However, I was so proud and arrogant, I believed that I could harness this power… I went to the other sorcerers with an offer, but they turned it down too. How angry I was with them. I thought I would become a true heroine, the savior of my world, a great heroine who All power was to be mine, and no one could match me. My disciple was carried away by these desires. He agreed to help me perform the ritual. We prepared ourselves, or at least we thought we were. But the being we summoned… I didn't understand what terrible power we summoned. My apprentice deviated from the ritual, and I hated him for it for many years. Now I know it was the smartest thing he could have done. The entity easily absorbed me and turned me into what I am. The Head Sorcerer came to prevent the ritual, but he arrived

too late. He enraged me, so I killed him, and then the whole council… Only my apprentice was spared. I ran away. I wanted to live so badly… So I swore to serve the same enemy I swore to fight. I was... a devoted servant... To a time” she took another big gulp from the bottle.

"But now you are with Lady Cala and with us! Everything will be fine.” Rosie said. Miss Daisy smiled sadly and stood up. She walked over to the deaf girl and touched her face with her clawed fingers.

"You're a good kid…" said Miss Daisy, but then pulled her hand away. „No, there are no bad kids. It's others who instill their evil in them ... I've learned that. Now forgive me, even in my state I have needs that I cannot avoid.” Rosie must have looked confused, because Miss Daisy smiled warmly. "I need to go to the toilet, then I'll try to take a nap." she said and went to their room.

Rosie stayed here a while longer, trying to digest what she had learned. She saw what power Miss Daisy wields, and that it is a dark force. But… She was kind to her and cared for someone as wonderful as Lady Cala. She couldn't be that bad..

.
Then she felt someone clapping behind her. She was so scared that she jumped. She turned, ready to face a potential attacker, but saw Eti standing with her face uncovered. She sighed with relief. In fact, she was glad to see it.

„Oh, it's just you!” She smiled at the feline girl.

„I am not just me. I am something great” Eti replied looking where Miss Daisy had disappeared.

„What are you doing here?” asked Rosie, looking at the strange girl.

„I think I'm wasting my time. I expected Grimmy to want to kiss you or suck your soul. Instead, I heard a tearful story.” she said and yawned.

„That would be terrible!” Rosie shuddered.

„What? Kissing girls or sucking souls…” Eti asked, raising an eyebrow.

„That's the second one!” said the deaf girl energetically.

„Oh, so kissing girls doesn't bother you ... „ said Eti, staring at the white-haired girl. Rosie felt herself blush. She decided to change the topic.

"Doesn't anyone worry that you're gone?" she asked, and Eti shrugged.

"They're more annoyed that I've avoided redecorating. You see, we have to prepare a ship for you. „ she thought for a moment. “Actually, I didn't realy suspect Grimmy of anything. She... sincere. Dark, a little scary, but sincere ... I don't like the other one, Reeka. There's something wrong with her, but I don't know what.” Eti said, staring thoughtfully into the night.

„But she's wonderfull.” protested the deaf girl.

Eti snorted.

„Those are the worst.” she said and wanted to go.

„And in your case... What happened to you? I mean your hand?” Rosie stopped her.

This time Eti smiled for the first time since meeting her. There wasn’t pleasant smile. There was something dangerous and predatory about him.

"A wonderful woman did this to me..." She ran into the night leaving Rosie confused.

Bina hated lying to her wards. Of course, she knew that they also sometimes stray from the truth. But more should be expected of her. Especially since it was a very serious lie. And it affected them

all. She was on the outskirts of Saltmarsh, in what was supposed to be a kind of plaza where whole families would hang out. Of course, the planet had fallen and now there was nothing but wasteland. She stood by the dry well and looked around, crossing her arms over her chest. She saw him sitting on some lamp post. The black raven stared at her as if she were a very funny creature.

„I see that the doctor is in a good mood. „ she said smiling. The bird with a loud floe landed on the ground and turned into a man. He was quite tall, dressed in a black tailcoat and wearing a top hat. He was wearing mirror glasses that reflected starlight. His face was pale, like the bird he had been a moment ago.
"Good night, Bina, and indeed, joy fills my heart." he said, bowing courteously.

„Are you suggesting you have a heart? You shouldn't, as a scientist, draw such far-reaching conclusions. Bina said smiling sarcastically. The doctor spread his hands in a helpless gesture.

„What harsh words! But since the courtesies are behind us... How's about Eti's hand.” he asked, showing his sharp fangs in an almost happy smile.

„I'm glad you asked about GIRL. All is well with Eti. She is healthy and reasonably content with life, as are all of us.” Bina said in an annoyed voice.

"She's a fascinating genetically engineered creature, but not even unique. But this hand ... - The doctor rubbed his hands clearly excited.

"Dr. Sidonius, you personally made sure she is unique." Bina said in a gloomy voice.

„Nonsense!” cried the Doctor indignantly. „The experiment was successful! There is no doubt about it!”

„Yes, your applesauce carton ... Well, we'll find out about everything on the spot, but don't count on miracles.” said the

thoughtful woman

„I don't count on miracles, I rely on them” Sidonius laughed heartily.

What a messed up son of a bitch you are she thought contemptuously,

” By the way, we visited the observatory. The good news is we found your maps and all the records are fine. Angry that we fought the bodak you summoned without informing us and the damn Azlanti. Bina snapped irritably.

-„Azlanti... I'm not surprised... But I have another message. The Lord Admiral is also heading deep into the Zone” Doctor Sidonius said, ignoring the bodak case. Bina uttered a bunch of curses.

„What's that son of a bitch doing there?” Captain of the Sword asked sharply.

„What's strange about it? He's been preparing for this trip all his life. And this time, he might succeed.” said the vampire.

„We take these guys from Kemanis University with us. They have maps not worse than ours and a lot of equipment. Only the cursed pirate, Captain Moonshadow, is flying with us.”

The doctor didn't seem surprised by the woman's presence.

„I know her ... we had an interesting conversation once. Just like me, she lost the most important part of herself ... the past ...” he said with full seriousness.

The Fearless Armada

Lord Admiral Antares closed his eyes as he was injected. The lumbar puncture wasn't particularly unpleasant, but then he had to lie on the bed for two hours, and that meant a terrible waste of time... And he had less and less time.

"It's all over," Lady Sorrowflame said in a polite but not obsequious voice. He nodded to her while the redhead prepared the cerebrospinal fluid for research. They were in his private quarters.

„When's the next dose?” he asked and straightened his clothes.

„In three days... For the next six months we should maintain such intervals between successive administrations.” said the ancient necrotechnician.

„And then?” he asked, rubbing his jaw.

„We will switch to daily doses ... This will give us another year, and then there will be some steps to be taken. We have several options…”

He was prepared for his health to deteriorate, but he needed time to carry out his plan. He has to rebuild his domain. Reclaim his legacy.

"Well, let's get down to business first. There is no escape from destiny.” he said. *I wasted so much time on one stupid mistake when I let myself get carried away by my emotions. It may be too late now* He sighed, but then Lady Ka approached him with a briefcase full of documents.

„I just need a few signatures here and there.” she said smiling half her face.

These two were the only people he allowed to be around him when he was weakened. He was not afraid of his subordinates and that they could use this moment to take power away from him. Paranoia was a sign of weakness, and he didn't tolerate it. He just didn't think soldiers should see their commander like this. That might make them doubt, and he didn't tolerate that either. He couldn't afford to let his subordinates hesitate at the crucial moment. And now was approaching the great moment for which he had been preparing for thirty-five years. Nothing could disrupt his plan

But those two… well. To Lady Sorrowflame, he was just a pity human being anyway, a tiny and frail creature who lived but a moment. And Lady Ka…. That woman had killed her Father, if that was the word for Jantar, so he couldn't expect her to respect him either. And that was one of the reasons why he… saved her.

"You're doing well Ka… This expedition is a gigantic challenge in terms of logistics. We don't know how much we can count on supplies from the Empire." he said, looking through the documents.

„We've got enough supplies for a few months, and it's unlikely that there's no supply anywhere in the empire. It's after all... the Empire, they exist to supply the invasion fleets.” she smiled nastily. He sighed and got up.

„We are not an invasion fleet, but a research and exploration fleet, and we must think of ourselves as such ... at least for a while. The public is extremely sensitive to appearances. We must be very careful not to make unnecessary enemies.”

Lady Ka raised an eyebrow.

„Do we have time to be careful? I don't need to remind you of the exchange that took place a moment ago, do I?” she asked.

Good point he thought. He considered his answer.

"Well, it's better to die a winner than a loser, I have no intention of leaving my fleet in trouble." he said in a serious tone. He was honest, this fleet was almost all he had. He was wealthy and could live on the wealth he had seized from Tarak, but it was the Fearless Armada and its upkeep and survival that he had devoted his life to. He led his subordinates as their rightful leader. She was all he had left after his enemies had taken his inheritance from him.

"As your rightful successor, I must commend your decision." said the woman in the half-mask. "So does Lady Sorrowflame, I suppose." she asked the necrotechnician.

„I'm not that fatalistic. Like I said, we have a lot of options. For example, Prime's technology" said the redhead in a calm voice, but Lady Ka winced.

"I know something about his technology…" she laughed nervously. „I know her limitations all too well."

"So far we only had damaged parts of his machines, now with a bit of luck we'll have access to the entire technical base with competent service..." said Lady Sorrowflame smiling greedily. *Yes, I know how easy it was to earn your loyalty. I should have appreciated her more, you are not one-tenth as treacherous as a certain doctor*

"I'm still not sure if it'll help... But I'd rather we did. My position is very comfortable." said Lady Ka smiling at the red-haired woman. He knew that the women had an intimate relationship, but decided that it was not a threat to him, so he did not intervene.

„There's something else. It is said that this region was the heart of the First Ones Empire, the ancient civilization that built the abandoned cities on Abbalon and the entire Anacite civilization. Their technology…" Lady Sorrowflame was speaking passionately, but he cut her off with a raised hand.

"It's fascinating and maybe we'll get some benefit from it, but I wouldn't count on finding anything that will help me. Not at the right time. Following the shadows of the ancient past can easily lead us to the marshes of doom.” he said, and the necrotechnician nodded, clearly dissatisfied, so he added. "We'll have enough resources so that after the first fights you can start your search and research…as long as it doesn't interfere with your daily work. I know how tempting the vision of seizing such an ancient power can be, but it can be extremely deceptive.” he said thoughtfully. He saw that the necromancer, herself as ancient as the First Ones, or at least not much younger, nodded her head in full acceptance of his decision.

"If I hadn't lost that artifact then... If it hadn't been taken from me..." she clenched her fists capable of crushing granite rocks.

"I lost something far more valuable than your toy then, don't forget that." he said firmly, feeling a cold flame ignite in his heart. It always did when he remembered how close he had been to complete victory. *Even in death, Igzar, you have been able to harm me. You have a right to be proud of yourself* he thought and extinguished his emotions. He didn't need them now, he had to remain unfazed.

„Yeah, too bad the trap didn't work” said Lady Ka touching her mask. "I miss my little kitty."

An hour after dawn there was to be an meeting with the Lord Admiral. Dilayla was about to see their command for the first time. The night passed peacefully, she was sleeping soundly as always after a fight, a useful trait in a mercenary. They rose early in the morning to prepare for this Great Event. And so it turned out that Miss Daisy was no longer asleep, but was wandering around the room obviously hungover, and Rosie looked as if she was about to fall asleep standing up. She sighed and shook her head. *I don't feel sorry for the gloomy old drunk, but how will this girl cope* she thought as she watched the deaf girl who leaned her head against

Emily. Wrongdak opened the window in the morning to ventilate the room, and then a fly lost after a night flight flew into the room. The insect buzzed irritatingly in the lazy stillness of the morning. He tried to sit on the white-haired girl, but then her hand shot up into the air and caught him. There was silence again. *Though admittedly, she was surprisingly resourceful for an absalomian intern, but she could also fight like no other* the mercenary thought. She had only seen such a fighting style once, with the aged Kasatha of Akiton, but this was a naive girl… Who didn't even know who she really was. This alarmed her. So far, she had considered her to be the only fully trustworthy person in the entire expedition. Now she wasn't sure of anything anymore. *You're getting paranoid, Rosie is the epitome of honesty and harmlessness* she thought. Wrongdak was helping Arkan-tar prepare breakfast. The clone had a secret too, but she had promised not to tell anyone the truth, and she saw no reason not to keep that promise. Another clone... One of his brothers had spared her during the war, though he most likely had orders to kill every creature he encountered, and most likely, he either died fighting the order or his master got rid of him... They said *He saw all. He knew all* and from the way their companion acted at the mention of Horde Prime's name, this may have been true... at least partly. The Wrongdak was clearly harmless… at least to those who weren't his enemies. Surely, if he wanted it, he was no less of a fighter than her. She trusted him and wanted to meet his friends. If they've done what the Order hasn't done... Then they have her gratitude and loyalty... They've given her something that all the money in the world can't buy... Justice she's been looking for all her life.

Unfortunately, Wrongdak seemed to be infatuated with Lady Cala. Perhaps it had to do with her charm. She had to admit that the woman was beautiful, graceful, and had impeccable manners. No wonder someone like him would like her. She knew a lot about interspecies relationships, after all, she came from Minitar, a planet of mix-bloods, and her first girlfriend was a half-orc, and she wasn't sure what the relationship between his "Older Brother" and "Friend" looked like ... Only there was no lust in it, but rather

... adoration ? It was as if he saw a supernatural and wonderful being in her… Maybe the representatives of his race showed respect in this way, after all, they were created in the likeness of this madman Horde Prime, as his followers and slaves. Apparently, he couldn't do otherwise... Being a follower of the inheritoress herself, she understood the comfort of faith and a sense of mission, so she wasn't going to sneer at him. Only she had the impression that Lady Cala was suspiciously comfortable with his veneration… Maybe all nobles were like that, she wasn't sure. All she knew was that she hated high-born officers with all her heart. They tended to treat their subordinates like dimwitted cattle that should have been grateful to die in the service of their lordship. *Damn, weren't we bloody Wrongdaks by our own consent* She laughed to herself and looked at the cheerful Lady Caly telling Rechiza about Carurystal in a cheerful tone. "But there's something more about her, something very strange," she thought as she looked at the beautiful woman. *She's perfect, unnaturally gorgeous... and how the hell did she get from the city to the observatory!* she thought.

She also lost confidence in the other two. Both Lashunti and Verthani were connected to the fucking vampire and his buddy Captain Freak, which they didn't deign to tell anyone. They probably won't tell the Lord Admiral either. She wouldn't care if it wasn't for the fact that her sister was on that damned Galeon, or at least what was left of her. It was all about the bunch of ancient races she didn't even know existed, and knowing about them didn't make her life any happier.

She didn't trust Miss Daisy either, but she didn't hide who she was…or what. Although that woman was a powerful and damn dark mystic, she was able to fight sorcerers, and she had several technomancers and Veskarian battle priests to her name. The other two looked like they might not have stabbed her in the back, but they wouldn't hesitate to sacrifice her if the need arose.. Miss Daisy looked too overwhelmed by grim fatalism to be able to plot anything. Plus, she was nice to Rosie, which made her feel much more warmly about her than about the damn rat watching

some elven soap opera at this moment. Miss Daisy stopped and looked at the monitor.

„How can you watch with such concentration how two beings argue for an hour.” she growled irritably.

"It's just life itself," Dr. Qin said, slurping from her glass so loudly that the grim elf winced.

„Life itself? Recently, a woman died because an empty cardboard box fell on her. I know very well how you can hurt someone in countless ways, but none of them involve a cardboard box falling on your head, especially an empty one.” the gloomy woman drawled

„You know, the actress wanted to leave the show after a hundred years”

Miss Daisy looked at Ysoki for a long moment.

“I know a lot of ways to ruin your life, but this one is both the most ridiculous and the most sophisticated. the dark sorceress finally said.

Although even in casual conversation, she she gives me shivers Dilayla thought, feeling lonely.

The mirror was set up in the room, although it cost them to listen to several bunches of curses from Dilayla, who apparently could smash heads, but setting up a simple "furniture" was clearly beyond her strength... on the other hand, constantly listening to Dr. Qin's lectures on how miror should be set, even Serenae, could drive a fiery rage. At that time, they sent Rosie with Emily and Wrongdak to the baths, because in space will be a water regime, although the droid was rather indifferent to it. At last everything was ready and it was time for the council. Arkan tar spoke the words and Lord Admiral Antares and his entourage appeared before her eyes. Rechiza struggled to stop herself from sucking in

a whistling breath. T*hey are really identical ... But at the same time completely different* she thought, looking at the woman in the half-mask, who smiled predatorily, like a shark from a lost Golarion to a defenseless seal. Commander Reese and Lady Sorrowflame did not arouse much interest in her, although she had heard that the red-haired woman's was curious about dark secrets and black magic...

The Lady of Blades was different. Asindesa di Vir seemed to pay no attention to her, although she knew that Rechiza was an agent of the Order. She bowed to Lady Caly, albeit slightly, but for a moment she had the distinct impression that the Lady of Blades and Miss Daisy's eyes met. Liktor told her that his foster daughter was a guest at Castle Grayskull, but no one knew what really happened there. *Did I see the sadness and pain in the eyes of the sorceress? s*he thought. Arkan-tar then reported back to their superior, omitting, of course, some of the points they had mutually decided they were going to omit, including Captain Moonshadow, which they had agreed on first thing in the morning. The Lord Admiral listened impassively until they mentioned the Alien and how it looked. She wasn't entirely sure, but she had the impression that Antares nodded slightly, and Lady Ka's smile became wider and more sinister. *Do they know something? Could they have somehow found out the truth about what really happened on the Minitar… But was there anything strange about it? Many years had passed since the invasion and word could have spread, and Dilayla wasn't the only one who witnessed those fights* she thought. Finally, after passing the report the Lord Admiral said

„We now know not only that the insatiable hosts of the Swarm are not waiting for us, but we learned who our enemy is and that he was mutilated like a steed with a broken leg. ” he waved his hand and from the shadowy darkness of the conference room came to him a huge creature resembling a wolf or a hyena. He had a long mane on the nape of his neck and was partially cybernetic. Its massive jaws were aided by cyber fibers, and its fangs were made of adamantium alloy. He had armor implanted under his skin, and his legs were hydraulically assisted and

equipped with retractable steel blades. Lashunti shuddered at the sight. Antares stroked the beast's neck.

„It's Resh. Nightmare Hunter. These creatures were created from our Nightmare Wolves of Tarak, which were modified by my long-lost friend Jantar, a brilliant biotech. They were useful during swarm fights for catching Dredgers, but they have many other advantages. Whoever this Horde Prime was, his army has a broken backbone, and he has thousands of battle-hardened veterans who have faced the galaxy's most feared foe... Still, it would be worth forging an alliance with whoever defeated him, if only to save our very limited resources. Think of it as your extra task. Find out who he is and discreetly explore the possibility of an ally. But don't let this obscure your main task, which is to find this weapon and deactivate it." finished the leader of the expedition in a hard tone.

„But there is a possibility that this weapon was created by this Horde Prime and was destroyed with his fall.” Arkan-tar interjected.

„Has someone decided that this venture is not for him and was looking for an excuse to withdraw?” Lady Ka asked in a sarcastic tone. The admiral ignored her and said.

„We can't be sure of anything yet. The fleet will deal with what's left of the Horde, and you'll gather information. In fact, little has changed in this matter." said the Lord Admiral.

Asindesa di Vir looked at the Lord Admiral warily.

„But then the participation of this fleet, and especially the fleet of the Order, seems to be pointless. Since the enemy seems to be leaderless and the weapon has probably been deactivated by those who defeated Horde Prime…”

„Or it's in their hands and they just haven't figured out how to activate it yet, but it's only a matter of time, dear knight. But I see that even the Order knows when to abandon ideals and start

listening to reason.” said Lady Ka, staring with one eye at the Hellknight, who pursed her lips furiously. Suddenly, she pulled the blade out and slammed it violently into the floor. Commander Reese winced at the sight

"Fo the honor of the Order of the Eclipse, I swear that it is not our intention to back down from the commitments we have made, as long as no one wants to use us to advance their particular interests." But I also swear that anyone who once again challenges my commitment to the cause will have to fight me openly. said sharply, glaring at Lady Ka, who looked like she was not afraid to take on the challenge, but the Lord Admiral signaled them to calm down.

"I am glad to hear your reassurances from the Lady of Blades, and I have no doubt that your forces will contribute greatly to our victory." That's probably all, Once you go into drift, we'll lock onto the mirror the man said calmly.

Rechiza, however, only partially listened to what Antares was saying, because she was staring at the sword of the Lady of Blades. It was covered in First Ones writing that apparently only she had noticed. The inscription said. "End of Eternity - Blade of Vengeance". No one but Miss Daisy noticed her staring at the HellKnight's weapon. "Another First One’s artifact. Random event? I'm too smart to believe them. I paid dearly for this wisdom"

The Lord Admiral felt that talking to the members of Lady Cala's Retinue, as he liked to think of them, lifted his spirits. First, he ultimately made sure Horde Prime was destroyed. His old friend wasn't the best source of information. Now he knew he was risking far less than he had feared. If they mint coins from such poor quality bullion, it means that their situation is bad. He had known their adversary over the years and knew their weaknesses. But they didn't know him... and when they do, they'll weep.

He looked sideways at the slightly soured Lady Ka. *There is one more reason to be pleased with the recent conversation*

„I see that it will be necessary to talk to our seller about the fact that he was a bit far from the truth when he talked about postponing the auction."

The woman in the half-mask pursed her lips tightly.

„Well, as you know, I can very vividly explain to others what a terrible mistake they made in their life by trying to deceive me. For the rest of their wretched lives, they will regret ..." she said in a quiet, thoughtful voice. This woman was a bit too emotional, but he appreciated her anyway. For ruthlessness and lack of sentiment. She could carry out even the most controversial order without batting an eyelid.

„That's good, but it's not that important. You don't have to express our displeasure to him very much. After all, we saved tens of thousands of credits. Let this mercy be an expression of our good mood." he said in the tone of a satiated cat.

She nodded, still internally furious with the trader, and went to carry out the order. He was on board a battleship on the bridge and gave his last orders to his subordinates. Commander Reese stood by his side. He had a sincere devotion to his commander that bordered on adoration. The Lord Admiral found it quite pleasant, though he did not allow the man to believe that he might have more. He did not like to mix pleasure with work. Besides, it could cause problems later on, and he needed this man's leadership skills. Plus, he was proud of what kind of man Reese had grown up to be. He had personally saved him many years ago on a swarm-infested planet. Back then, the commander still used the pronoun *she* and was a terrified orphan. He made him his Adjutant, and after Markus stayed on Atrax to oversee Lord Admirał business there, he made Reese his right-hand man. Now they were calling in more ships, telling them to report their readiness for flight in Drift. He smiled as he saw the list of ships.

Battleship *Glory of the Fallen*

Spacecraft carrier *Unbroken* with 16 Defender fighters

Heavy cruiser *Invictus*

Intredictus-class cruiser: *Necessary Measures*

Two Moonlight-class cruisers: *Silvermoon* and *Goldsun*.

Dagger-class escort carriers: *Silver knife* and *Obsidian Edge*. 8 defender fighters each.

Eight Freedom-class destroyers

Four Wildcat-class torpedo ships.

Helping hand tanker.

Mining ship Sargar and Repair ships *Skrek* and *Drek*

A dozen heavy transport ships and three times as many smaller ones.

In addition, they had over thirty thousand soldiers of the ground forces. Most of them were seasoned veterans of Tarak and the Swarm Wars or Vescs voluteer. To that he could add the ten thousand hired thugs and scum employed by Lady Ka. Although their combat capabilities were not very great, they were great as law enforcement forces to suppress riots. You also have to remember about Lady Sorrowflame and her necrotechnical inventions, it was also a force to be reckoned with. During the review, he smiled for the first time in months. “Here I am embarking on the journey for which I have been preparing all my life. I come to fulfill my destiny, and even if I have to burn whole worlds, I will not back down."

Grag was packing hurriedly. He intended to leave this damm planet before midnight. He must have left most of his fortune on Saltmarsh. In recent years, he has grown rich on this cursed planet, opened a department store, gained contacts among the leaders of local gangs, but also in the capital's authorities. But he knew he couldn't go any higher, and he had to get the money from somewhere to pay off his debts to the *Thousand Sisters* and finally be able to return to Atrax, where he had old friends and, most importantly, hidden credits. He'd be living decently again, not selling manure to Shirren farmers. That's why he got involved in this damned auction. Capturing this White Demon seemed like a great idea, what could possibly go wrong? *A bunch of robbers have stolen the most expensive stuff I've ever had my hands on, and now they're going to sell it and screw all that money into stupid stuff There is no justice in this world*, he thought and wanted to kick the carton of turnips, but stopped himself just in time. Despite the use of advanced and expensive drugs, the leg injured by the elf still hurt so much that he wanted to writhe in pain with every step. He didn't take painkillers, though, he hated having anything cloud his mind. His bodyguard Krat, who had been with him since the days of Atrax, stood with his chitin plastered and looking pathetic. He promised the insectoid that he would take it with him, but he wasn't sure if he would be able to fulfill that promise. Well, in this world, everyone should only count on themselves. His Shirren employees knew this, and they left him right after he was robbed. Well, they knew when to get out of a depressurized ship... But he had plans, big plans. Maybe he'll make it to Damaiko? At least it'll be fun there. He looked around the room where he had lived for the last few years. There wasn't much here. A narrow bed, several cupboards and a stool with a chair. Well, he didn't leave much behind, and that was good.

„Come on Krat, we made it. Neither that devil- and demon-cursed pirate and speciesist Azlanti got me.” he said and took a deep breath. Then the Door swung open violently. The nasty-looking gnome threw an ax that shattered the insectoid's head. An elf with a deathly white face and an extremely nasty Shirren rushed

inside. The elf jumped on him, putting the saber to his throat, and the insectoids looked around the room and said.

„The area is clear.”

And then a woman walked in, who he wished was Moonshadow.

"Oh Grag, I don't think you're going anywhere." she said and laughed in her typical insane way.

„Oh, Supreme Queen Ka. If I knew… He started to speak pleadingly, but she cut him off.

"Just Lady Ka, at least for now." she said and signaled to the elf who pushed him to her knees. He howled in pain but quickly recovered himself. He had to appease her somehow, or it would be much worse

"So what did you do with our pale friend? You went for a walk, but he saw a cat and ran away?” she asked in a deadly sweet voice. Grag laughed.

„And you know that's somewhat true. I was attacked by a bunch of kids. Crazy and armed. And among them was Pahtra with a strange metal hand...”

Then Ka looked at him in surprise, then said appreciatively.

„Well, Grag, I think you saved your worthless life ... and I found the trail of the Lord Admiral's missing kitty.”

Shadow of the Past - Journey to Kranor Rill

She woke up.

She heard the buzzing of the insects that inhabited this accursed swamp. The bloodthirsty bastards wanted nothing more than to disturb her peace. Fortunately, they had no intention of feeding on her blood, an unexpected advantage of her state of health. Everything in the tent was damp, she couldn't keep warm under the blankets. Her body ached from lying on the ground and riding those damn mechanical horses, though she didn't want to take Shadow on this trip because she was afraid her favorite horse would go lame or something else would happen to her. She got too attached to it. *Who would ever have thought that you would worry that something might happen to your horse. The sufferings of Catra and Adora, your daughters, did not concern you* She thought and smiled bitterly. She stood up feeling pain in all her bones. *Is this rheumatism? Could I have rheumatism?* she thought in surprise. *What's on your mind, old witch? You've never been a fan of outdoor adventures. You've seen virtually no wildlife in the last thirty years, except for that brief period of occupation by the Galactic Horde, and it's been no better before. You were used to a comfortable life, even in the Fright Zone, where you had incomparably better conditions than those poor kids forced to grow up in your… shadow. Now you want to play monster slayer and this is the price you have to pay for it. So focus and don't let such inconveniences distract you,* she thought and stretched, feeling her bones cracking. Then she left the tent.

Their camp didn't look very professional. The whole expedition had been summoned on an ad hoc basis when she wrote to several powerful landowners living near those cursed swamps… The tents were set up haphazardly with no plan, just closer to the fires. Guards were posted randomly, and she had the impression that most of the guards spent more time on drinking than guarding the camp. With one glorious exception…

"You're not sleeping…" said Asindesa di Vir staring into the darkness of the night. The stars above them shone brightly, for they were far from any source of industrial or light pollution. There was no industrial center for hundreds of miles, and they had left their last settlement of Fort Bitterdale two days ago, to the dubious looks of soldiers and trappers. *I'm actually in the most Etheria-like place I've ever seen on this planet if it weren't for the stars*

„I don't really need to sleep. Sometimes it's just my mind that needs to turn off... Otherwise, I start acting a bit maniacal, or I fall into depression...” she said staring at the lamp around which moths and mosquitoes were flying. „I don't have to eat either, I can draw energy from the magic permeating the world ... But I can also eat in a different way if necessary.” she directed her hand towards the insects and dark purple energy flowed towards her. The insects fell dead to the ground.

"If I hadn't held your hand in my hand and felt your pulse…" said the hellknight, smiling slightly. She was glad that it was dim, because she had the irresistible feeling that she was blushing.

"I'm something of a magic-eating parasite." she said, *A monster… A sadist who enjoys hurting children*

„Are there many such creatures in the place where you come from?” asked the Lady of Blades, looking askance at her.

„No... Now there's not one left. *May there be no one like me there. The nightmare cannot happen again*.

They were silent for a moment, listening to the sounds of night.

„Do you have someone? Someone other than Lady Cala?” the Lady of Blades asked after a moment.

It's Lady Cala Has Me

:No... Just a half-elf servant Leris... I don't have time for friendship or... things like that. I socialize with most of the

important people on the planet…but nothing more than that.” she said in a firm tone. She had the impression that Asindesa was satisfied with her answers.

„And invthe place where are you from ... Waldenese?” asked the hellknight after a moment.

This time she had to think seriously about her answer, because… she wasn't sure what it should sound like. She knew she'd hurt a lot of people in her life, not just Adora and Catra, not just Mikah. The hundreds of kids she had raised to be soldiers, Scorpions, poor rebel soldiers, even that son of a bitch Hordak. He too was a pawn in her game, though she had never even been a player.

„No ... There was no one left there who could remember me fondly.” *Even you Glimmer and Castaspella. Not after they found out what I did to Mikah* she thought bitterly. She was lost in bitter thoughts again. Suddenly she felt the touch of a strong grip on her shoulder. She shuddered.

„Did something happen?” Asindesa asked anxiously. She immediately took her hand away.

„No ... Because of my condition, I got weaned to touching.” she replied carefully

Ever since the ritual, she hated being touched. Once, when it was cold because the central heating in the Fright Zone had failed, Catra came under her blanket. When she noticed this, she threw the girl away and slapped her hard in the face. Cara never touched her in a friendly way after that. She also never hugged Adora, although she often assured her that she was important to her. In all these years, she'd only been hugged once, by that overjoyed flower girl... How was she... Perfuma?

„Is… Can't you be helped somehow? I remember there was a girl in our Order once. The explosion left her with only a shred of flesh, but thanks to magic and technology, she was able to lead an almost normal life.”

She smiled sadly and shook her head.

„ No... It's as it should be. And even if ... No one can reverse it. I've been working on it for thirty years... However, it's only recently that I've learned what's really wrong with me. There is no force in the entire galaxy that could reverse this process... But it's better than it used to be. Much better. But thank you for your sincere willingness to help.” she tried to make her smile a little happier, but it always came with difficulty.

- You're welcome... We're together... on this journey and we need to support each other

The idea for a trip to the cursed swamps of Kranor Rill came when she listened to a radio message about another attack on a settlement located near the swamps, although beyond the security cordon. Many of the planet's inhabitants were furious at the archduke's inaction. But he was not going to intervene. Apparently, he did not want to inflame the conflict with the inhabitants of immeasurable swamps, although apparently the situation was slowly getting out of control. Kranor Rill has doubled in size in the last dozen or so years and has swallowed up more and more settlements…

Hearing this, she couldn't help but smile bitterly. She remembered the beginnings of the Horde invasion and the passivity of most of the princesses who had no idea how to deal with the unknown threat. Of course, the actions of the Old King also had an impact on the whole situation, and without his support, Hordak would never have gained a foothold on her home planet. *Only if we are not the Horde of this world. Or worse, the First Ones?* she thought grimly, but truth be told, Carurystal matters would soon cease to be her concern... But she had a very important job to do... She had to meet with Asindesa di Vir... as she possessed extremely valuable information necessary for their mission. Besides, the Lady of Blades could prove to be an extremely valuable ally... Yes, by trying to make friends with her, she will undoubtedly contribute to

the cause of Creeping Chaos. And couldn't there be a better way to get close to her than to go against ruthless monsters like the Riliti? After all, it was the job of the hell knights to spread order in place of Chaos! So she had a plan.

First, she decided to use her authority on Carurystal and sent handwritten letters to several of the most important families whose estates were located near Kranor Rill. In it, she expressed concern about the whole situation and expressed her desire to solve this pressing problem. The results… They weren't spectacular to say the least. Most answered her politely that it was a big problem affecting all of them, but what could they do? Many did not seem to understand her intentions, or at least claimed that they did not understand ... Such was life in a world where conventions and appearances ruled society. Sometimes she longed for the brutal honesty of social relations in the Horde, where at least she would have been explicitly refused instead of meandering around the subject…

The others told her that they would consider her proposal, but first she had to present them with a plan of action ... But what could she do, since she had no plan? Adora and her friends usually improvised, with surprisingly good results... But the Carurystalans were more cautious. So she had to go to the library, and even use the web, to come up with even the outline of something resembling a plan. This time her passion for perfection and meticulousness paid off, though she also couldn't forget that it was the transformation that allowed her to work twenty hours straight. Leris brought her food and tea, in this state she felt no need to drink alcohol, the work itself was the greatest reward. The girl seemed to worry more and more about her, but she couldn't help it. The half-elf was an orphan born in a nearby village, her parents were said to have died in a Riliti attack, though she later learned that they died in a road accident. Ho*w prosaically random* she thought bitterly. She appreciated the girl's help and liked to look after her, it would be a pity to leave her here when she went on a great journey with Lady Cala, but taking her would be an act of sheer cruelty, too much even for her.

The most important thing she managed to get from the net were satellite maps of the entire Kranor Rill area. She wasn't a geologist or a biologist or anything like that, just maybe knew a fair bit of botany, but her years working for Hordak had given her a basic understanding of a wide variety of things. She noticed with concern that the marshes spread evenly, forming an almost perfect circle. She had always liked symmetry, but seeing it in nature, and on this scale, was instinctively uneasy. But it could be more than that, she thought in amazement and felt a surge of excitement. Perhaps before he leaves Carurystal behind will discover something of value, she will uncover an ancient secret from thousands of years ago. *Ancient secrets usually mean bitter truths that won't make anyone happier to discover* she warned herself, but continued her work and was surprised to find that she enjoyed it... She always sought knowledge, even that which made ordinary beings fearful and disgusted. …

The library of Grayskull Castle was not awe-inspiring, especially for such an old and respectable family. Lady Cala's ancestors were not intellectuals, and there were often missing basic volumes that every educated citizen should know ... Obtaining them in such a way that no one realized the extent of her ignorance was a bit difficult for her. This time she preferred to go to the Archduke's library in Lynortis. It was probably the best-stocked place on the planet, and she should have no problem finding the information she needed there. It took her several hours to get there, and she had to rent a hotel room, another thing she had never done before serving her new Lord. Fortunately, her experience of studying and teaching in Mystacor and supervising the Fright Zone meant that she had no difficulty in navigating the nooks and crannies of such institutions. The problem came from a completely different side, which as a person born on Etheria, she usually did not remember ... The inhabitants of the galaxy forgot about their past ... They lost it forever ...

Little was known about the past during the Gap, most knowledge of what had been going on for millennia had been lost. On Etheria, most people didn't care about the history of their world after the First Ones *left* it. They lived a peaceful and relatively

happy life in a world where seemingly nothing ever changed, though so much had happened over the millennia... The loss of two runestones, the loss of two schools, and the conflict of heirs... She who was born in the Isles of Sorrow knew best about that. They had the opportunity to know their past, even if incomplete and limited. And the inhabitants of the galaxy were deprived of it. At the same time, it made her work horribly difficult…

She let out another moan of frustration. She never took failure well, even when she was teaching in Mystacor, and the entire Fright Zone trembled with her outbursts of rage. Serving first Glimmer and then Cala's, she had to learn to control herself. Now she wanted to tear apart those two hundred pages of books about the salinity of the water in Kranor Rill. *It's ridiculous. Hasn't anyone been interested in what the darkest corner of the planet hides for these three hundred years? Is there anyone here who would be fascinated by forbidden knowledge? Anyone like me?* she laughed grimly, though she wanted to howl in helplessness. "I can't fail now. Not in this case. Must... must succeed..." She didn't know why she was so keen on this endeavor... "Not my dear Shadow Weaver... You know what's going on with you. You know well, old twisted witch. You know, but you don't want to accept it like she couldn't…" She dug her claws into the desk and ran them all over the surface, leaving deep scratches. There was nothing else she could do.

„Excuse me, but can I help you with something?" she heard a hard male voice behind her back. Instinctively, she rose and summoned the power of the shadows, ready to freeze the attacker's heart. In front of her, she saw Archduke Adamson, who was smiling mysteriously at her. He was a tall man with blood red hair. He was a powerfully built with a wild, brutal look. But what caught my eye the most was his eyes. Light blue, they seemed to glow with an inner glow. But not like Adora's, it was rather a cold fire from the heart of winter. However, despite his appearance, he had impeccable manners worthy of a true aristocrat. He was an extremely well-educated man and had knowledge on almost every subject, although he was also said to be an undefeated warrior. His name was... She couldn't remember... it was Kane?

"I am seeking knowledge of the Kranor Rill, Your Majesty, for I wish to organize an expedition to… limit its influence…" she said hastily, unsure of what to do in such an unexpected encounter with the planet's ruler. *Be careful, this isn't the grieving Glimmer or the ever-furious Hordak. His family has ruled this planet for… forever, and they are not easily fooled by a cunning witch like you*

"Kranor Rill…" he said, a strange note in his voice. "This is not a place a lady of good birth would want to go to." he said in a surprisingly pleasant voice. She could never get over how much his voice didn't match his looks. "You shouldn't be surprised at that, should you?"

"Before becoming a steward I held other positions that often required me to deal with issues much more directly." she said, bringing a polite smile to her face, although there was something instinctively fearful about this man, as if she was talking to a wild beast let into the salons.

„Really?" he asked rhetorically. "Then you must be bored in our provincial Carurystal." His voice was lazy and curious at the same time, like a well-fed cat seeing a mouse.

"Until now, most of my attention has been devoted to preparing Lady Cali for adult life and managing her estates. Now that she's off to the Pact Worlds on her errands, I have some free time. „she actually said truthfully.

„And you decided to remember how it used to be. he finished the thought. Although a trip to this place is an unusual idea. Fortunately, you found someone who undoubtedly knows more about it than anyone else. Have you read *The History of the Elder Race*s by Ajora Zrorkros?" he asked curiously.

„I'm hearing about this title for the first time." *But the mention of the Elder Races sent shivers down my spin*e

The Archduke nodded his approval.

„That's good. Wrong or incomplete knowledge is more dangerous than ignorance. I know something about that…” he said, and for a split second she thought she saw a shadow of nostalgia or longing in those cold blue eyes.

„It is said that Kranor Rill did not arise naturally. Apparently, before the winds, a spaceship of an ancient race crashed there.” he said thoughtfully, and she shivered hearing those words that brought to mind an all-too-familiar story.

"So these Riliti are just castaways who have lost their ancient knowledge?" she asked, surprised and a little scared. *Am I going to meet a lot of Hordaks?*

„In a way, yes... Many see them as wild and cruel beasts. The truth, however, is a bit more interesting.” he said and looked into her eyes. "They're bioroids. Artificially created beings, living robots without… full intelligence. They served an ancient force powerful and sinister.” he spoke in a strong voice worthy of a lecturer or minstrel. *Oh what won't you say. Ancient malevolent beings bio-engineering hordes of servants is not something I ever expected* she thought, barely keeping herself from bursting into hysterical laughter. *Something strange is happening to me... It's because of the stress*

"Could Your Majesty tell me more about this?" she asked, hoping she didn't show that she had almost lost control. For a moment, she thought she saw an inscrutable glint in the eyes of the Lord of Carurystal.

"In the old days, a race tried to harness power through geomantic constructs that were overseen by crystalline computers, self-aware entities, created as part of a web that was supposed to bind the whole universe together, make it a single structure…" he said, and she tried to stop her body from trembling. . „But there was a rebellion, the crystals wanted to take over and enclose the world in their symmetrical structure, in order to gain power overshadowing that of the gods. Yet they were annihilated almost without exception. The last of them was destroyed by one of my

ancestors thousands of years ago ...” he said. She felt relieved, but anxiety still smoldered in her heart.

"I understand, but Riliti… Do they still carry out their creator's orders?" she asked, pondering the implications of what she had just heard. The Archduke considered his answer for a moment before speaking.

„Maybe, but I don't know for sure. All I can tell you is that in the center of Kranor Rill is the city of Arelarti. The center of all the infrastructure of this fragment of the structure Look for answers there. Or questions.” He finally said and left. There was one question she had to ask him, though.

„The creators of these crystalline computers... Were they human-like?

It was probably the first time in years that someone had surprised the Lord of Carurystal.

„Human-like? Not at all. They were reptiles. It is from them that Riliti was created. Well, that's certainly not what they expected from their creations... But we're often destroyed by our own creations, don't you think?”

She should have been relieved to know she hadn't gotten into the mysteries of the First ones again, but... the fate of Riliti's ancestors sounded all too familiar...

It had taken her a week to get everything ready, and she had decided that she should have spent much more time on it, but the Archduke's tales had given her no peace. Besides, Lady Cala’s had been gone for almost half a year now, and she feared that the day of her return was drawing near. She had to… get the information before that happened.

Few answered her call, mostly a few bored descendants of wealthy families, young and stupid, or a few old military men who

had never seen a fight in their lives. Most came with their own equipment, although it was hardly adapted to conduct operations in such an area. Logistics was one of the elements of warfare that she understood, and she hoped that at least that aspect of the expedition would succeed. General Harmus, the commander of Fort Bitterdale, agreed to sell her some of his surplus supplies and gave her the maps he had, but he could not offer her the support of his troops, because Commander General Rafel personally forbade military expeditions into the Kranor Rill, although she was not authorized to do the same with private ventures. They stayed in a shelter, and some of their subordinates were placed in private homes. In total, there were about twenty people. Although theoretically the highest military post was held by Retired General Elisa Nortingthon, a half-elf from a wealthy family, she found herself unsuited for the job, as she was only an honorary commander, so she proposed Sir Rakim, Vesk and a devoted follower of Imodae, he inheritor, whom many considered as a goddess of humanity, though she had many followers of all races among her faithful. In addition. Elf girl named Krianess, follower Eloritu, volunteered to become their "Science Officer", although she had never even thought of creating such a position. She felt off balance, hated to lose control of the course of events. But this time she had to accept it. "Because these are not helpless children trembling at your wrath, whom you might have broken to force obedience. You have to accept their decisions and, as always, bow before those stronger than you." She thought bitterly as she drank the locally produced whiskey, a very good one she had to admit. But there was something else. Rakim and Krianess were mystics devoted to higher powers, gods many times more powerful than mortals like her. They sent power and favors in exchange for devotion, at least that's what it looked like to outsiders. She spent most of her life among the non-religious, though strongly spiritual Etherians, or in the extremely materialistic Horde. All the prayers and rituals looked ridiculous and unsettling to her, and devotion to a higher power reminded her too much of the madness of Horde Prime, or the darkness of the creature she had sold her soul to.
But not heart and mind. You can be proud of yourself in that regard, my dear Shadow Weaver

However, the biggest disappointment was the lack of the one for which she organized this venture. Asindesa did not come, and she felt that she no longer cared about all this. *Maybe it's time to call off all that chutzpah. I'm just kidding. It was all the pathetic idea of an old idiot who thinks she's a teenager all along anyway* she thought bitterly and poured herself another glass of whiskey, looking sadly at the rest of the company cheering happily as if she was going on a picnic. Actually, it wasn't very different from what she was used to on her home planet. Despite all their differences, the inhabitants of Carurystal and Etheri shared a naive ignorance of the darkness that the galaxy hides and a belief that they are the center of the universe. When she was thinking so grimly, the shelter door opened wide and a figure stood in them, at the sight of which her heart beat faster. The whole room fell silent and looked at their new visitor.

"I am Asidesa di Vir, Lady of the Blades of the Order of the Eclipse." I would like to register my participation in this expedition. the knight said in a serious voice. She was dressed in the full armor of her order, and she had a sword in her sheath. Rakim stood up and asked her.

„It is an honor to welcome such an eminent person among us in our humble company. Does this mean that the Order will want to support this Expedition with its forces?”

Asidesa shook her head.

„No, I came here on the call of a friend.” said the Lady of Blades and gave her a friendly smile.

Part two: Ruins of the Empire - Into the darkness

They had been adrift for three days now, and Bina had settled into the ship's usual routine. Meals, system checks, training, drill alarms, and arguing about game rules, verbal scuffles, throwing paper birds… the usual. But this time it was different. And you could feel it every step of the way.

First of all, they had passengers. This wasn't the first time they'd carried visitors, perhaps even more unusual or suspicious ones. But they were different.

Arkan-tar, Doctor Quin, and Rechiza would have in different situation enjoyed their own company, rarely leaving their cabins. Actually, if it was about an ysoki scientist, it was even like that. Arkan-tar was polite but a bit overly curious, and Rechiza looked as if she was constantly afraid of something. This didn't surprise her, after all, they were going to the most cursed part of the galaxy. Though she should have known where she was going and what danger she was dealing with. Bina guessed that her behavior might be related to the loss of her eyes and antennae. She didn't met many Lashunti, so she didn't know what effect such a mutilation might have on them. Plus, she was a witchwarper, the strangest and most unpredictable kind of spel caster. Bina wanted to keep an eye on her, but if she could keep an eye on everything that worried or disturbed her, she would look like a legendary beholder.

The next three interfered much more in the lives of her crew. Dilayla, Rosie and Wrongdak gained a certain level of trust and sympathy among her crew members, which was not so easy considering how distrustful they were. She was happy about it, because she always wanted her charges to open up to the world.

Rosie was a nice, if somewhat naive, girl who managed surprisingly well despite her deafness. She was so different from Bina's kids that it was hard for her to believe someone like that could still walk the earth, though perhaps she had a warped perspective? She was so used to the weirdness and otherness of her charges that normality was something incomprehensible to her. Rosie became friends with the crew, especially Eti. Of course, this caused the resentment of itel, who was jealous of her *just friend*. She was glad that Eti had befriend with someone from the outside, and not that she wanted to wound that person. Rosie gladly joined the four friends, ignoring the green-haired elf's grumbling about the fifth wheel on the cart. After a few days, even the solarian stopped being rude to the white-haired girl, though Bina wasn't sure if it wasn't an agreement between Itel and Eti. She was afraid that complications might arise from this in the future.

Dilayla was a mercenary, though different from those she had ever met in her life. The woman had been mutilated in her early youth, supposedly attacked by invaders from deep within the ravaged zone, relatives of the sympathetic white-skined alien. She was very protective of Rosie, albeit in a completely innocent way. She mentioned that she once had a sister herself, but she had lost her long ago ... She herself had never known true sisterly love, but she could understand that now she was transferring those feelings to Rosie. She was also friendly towards Wrongdak, though Bina wasn't sure exactly why, especially since it was his kind that had maimed her.

Wrongdak… She wasn't sure what to think of him. He was a gentle and friendly creature by all means, but… he came from the place they were going to. He was a member of some Horde that was terrorizing the entire Zone. He had been a soldier himself, though not for long from what she could tell. The most important thing was that he was a clone. It made her uneasy, but it shouldn't have been. After all, she herself was one of Jantar's Thousand Daughters, or rather the Thousand Sisters as they were

now called. *Maybe that's what it's all about. It's hard to accept that you weren't unique in the hurt you suffered. Somebody else was as crazy a son of bitch as your Father* she thought grimly. Wrongdak even now as he spoke of his creator, this Horde Prime, was full of rage and fear. However, she had to admit that Wrongdak turned out to be a really nice and useful addition to her crew. He was strong, technically gifted and willing to help, although the latter may have been the result of spending a few years among Skittermaders. He also didn't mind Eti for attacking him and for treating him contemptuously. He occasionally watched her surreptitiously and asked the ship's captain questions about the feline girl, though of course he received only vague answers. Eti reminded him of his friend. And that could mean that she had survived Dr. Sidonius's crazy experiment... She should be glad about it, but if Eti met the other one... Will the conditioning kick in?

And there were the other two. Miss Daisy and Lady Cala. The grim elf had something strange about her and was a powerful and dark sorceress. She quickly began teaching them, as per the agreement they had made, and admittedly, she was quite good at it. She taught them the basics of linguistics, rhetoric and even calligraphy and drawing. She taught them the basics of good manners and economics, and even philosophy. In one discussion with Itel, it came to light that he was quite knowledgeable about miltary. She was also an excellent storyteller, though in Bina's opinion there were too many princesses in her stories. She was friendly to Rosie, and the white-haired woman seemed to feel very sorry for her. She and Eti had a certain connection, which was even weirder, and of course Itel was jealous. There was something else. Once she heard whispers between Arkan-tar and Rechiza. Lashunti mentioned something about "Her Face" while glancing at Miss Daisy. She wasn't sure what it was exactly, but then she had the impression several times that the woman's face glitched, although it was probably just an illusion caused by the power of suggestion.

And of course there was Lady Cala. The young woman was an absolutely extraordinary aristocrat, a beautiful, strong and smart

young woman. Which was probably the most obvious reason why Eti hated her. She could be overwhelming, and the company of a fair-haired aristocrat was a little overwhelming. Only Eti, of course, hissed at her whenever she passed by. She also sprayed hand sanitizer on everything she touched. Eti has always been ... specific and had her weirdnes. It was weird even for her though. She believed the feline ward that she could smell a strange and unpleasant smell, after all, she had an excellent sense of smell and hearing. Lady Cala herself admitted that she suffers from a rare disease and because of this, her body may emit a strange smell. Bina saw no reason not to believe the aristocrat… Well, Eti should sometimes think about how her room smelled after being locked up in it for a few days and not airing it out. Although sometimes when she watched Lady Grayskull, especially during training, when she won exacly three-quarters of her matches with itel and Lilka, she had the irresistible feeling that there was something strange about her ... *No one is so perfect*

Besides, she had the impression that the relationship between Miss Daisy and Lady Cala was much more complicated than it appeared. The aristocrat assured that the grim elf was like a second mother to her, and the one who introduced her to adult life. She was her friend and mentor. The dark sorceress was much more reserved, but she was generally a very reserved person. However, she had an irresistible impression that their relationship was much ... colder. Perhaps that was how well-born behaved. The women whispered among themselves, but did nothing really suspicious… except for one incident

It was the second day of the flight. It was quite quiet, everyone was resting after the systems review. Wrongdak was snoring loudly in the cabin he shared with Dilayla, Arkan-tar was reading some philosophy book borrowed from Eti, and so on. Rosie knelt beside Emily, examining the Skittermanders' drawings on Emily. Her eyes hurt from looking at her if anyone asked her opinion. Then Miss Daisy and Lady Cala entered the saloon where members of her small crew usually socialized. The noblewoman knelt beside Rosie, who immediately turned to her. This Droid was surprisingly fond of the Carurystal woman.

„You see Lady Cala this scar? How you think, how Emily got her. Wrongdak avoids explanation, but it looks like a wild beast attack to me?" the girl asked in sign language. Lady Cala puffed out her cheeks as if considering something. Miss Daisy stood back and looked at them.

"It could have been something much worse, my dear Rosie. A domesticated beast gone feral. Once my dad, may his soul rest in peace, used to tell me about his experiences in the circus. He was there at the performance of a certain tamer who was supposed to tame three wild beasts. A giant insect, a bizarre purple monkey, and a disgusting feline monster. The handler intimidated the insect and the monkey without much effort, but the feline monstrosity pounced on him and crippled him forever. The father was shocked, but another tamer with much more experience sitting next to him said that what he had witnessed was in fact a display of sheer incompetence. Many trainers are cruel to the animals they train, but only focus on intimidating them enough to obey and follow orders. But they remember who hurt them and are just waiting to pay back, all it takes is a moment of weakness ... A real tamer does not stop at submission. He mercilessly breaks the animal so that the mere thought of rebellion is terrifying to it" explained the aristocrat, and the white-haired woman looked at her in horror.

„It's terrible! How… how can someone do such things to another being." she said terrified. Lady Cala put a hand on her shoulder.

„I asked my father the same question and he couldn't find a good answer. The only thing we are able to do is not go to circuses and the like, such people did not earn money and support laws protecting animals." She patted Rosie's back and stood up. Bina would agree by all means, but she had the feeling that she was missing something. Some nuance that only these women understand… Throughout the story, Miss Daisy stood still, her fists clenched tighter and panting heavily. *Why did this story make her so angry? What happened here that I can't see* she asked herself in her mind. As Lady Cala was about to leave, Rosie asked her.

„And this beast, that's what happened to her?

The aristocrat looked at the deaf girl sadly.

„In a better world, someone would have mercifully shot her, but unfortunately, she was adopted by a dorky knight, a follower of Iomadae. Just wait for the tragedy, because once warped personality can not be fixed.

Miss Daisy left exuding fury. „This is too much for me" thought Bina.

And finally, there was their absolutely unplanned companion, Captain Moonshadow. Bina had no real prejudice against pirates and other dark-star types. She herself was literaly „born" into the gang. She wasn't sure if she wanted to cooperate with this woman. According to rumors, she was either a freedom fighter and slayer of the vile Azlanti, or a deranged psychopath who didn't care about any conventions about respecting the lives of captives. Her first encounter with the pirate suggested that both opinions might be true. But then it was time to determine the route of the flight. Captain Moonshadow made contact via the links, and her masked face appeared on the screen. Arkan-tar, Lady Cala, Wrongdak, as well as Eti and Itel were present.

"So, we must reach Etheria, but our task is also to collect enough data on this place for possible future expeditions." Arkan-tar said. Meanwhile, the itel and Lady Cala turned on the holographic map, onto which they had mapped data from the maps in Lady Cala's possession, those given to them by the old leech and found in the accursed observatory, and those at the disposal of Captain Moonshadow. They exchanged their data, although the pirate came out was much better at it. But they didn't want to make an enemy out of someone like that. On the other hand, he won't learn anything new anyway, because the maps largely overlapped.

"My crew is all about wealth, so if we find treasure along the way, I'm willing to go a bit off track." She pressed the word a bit hard.

„We can't promise much.” said Lady Cala. "Especially someone like you." Please forgive my bluntness.” she bowed politely to Captain Moonshadow.

„Please don't forgive her. We'll throw her out the airlock.” Eti interjected suddenly, but Bina glared at her. Fortunately, no one reacted to what the girl said.

„I'm not a noblewoman with a gentle heart, so that I have to sneer hearing a few words of truth.” The pirate bit back.

„Erm." Arkan-tar grunted. "Back to our discussion. I suggest we visit a few of these planets first.” showed a couple of systems on the way to Etheria. „Rather, there is nothing interesting there, because earlier expeditions would have discovered something, but it's worth checking.”

„I agree”. Moonshadow said. “Uninhabited planets have some value, and people like me can get some benefit out of them.”

„That's nice, but note that we have limited supplies, and our crew has kind of doubled. Bina interjected, crossing her arms over her chest. They still had a fair amount of overstock, but she preferred to be careful.

"I'm sure we'll have an opportunity to restock along the way," said Lady Cala.

„I can give you something too. My crew consists of decent people for pirates.” added the strange pirate. Bina had to admit that at least she was kind to her charges, despite their quirks.

„It doesn't matter. There's nothing there, nothing anymore.” Wrongdak said in a gloomy voice joining the discussion. They all looked at him as if only now noticing that he was there.

„Please explain?” Bina asked anxiously. She had never seen a alien in such a gloomy mood.

„They rejected the light of Horde Prime. They were unworthy of his love.” he said quietly, staring at his feet.

„ What do you mean. Itel asked pale, apparently the first to guess the truth.

„He killed them. all of them. Entire civilizations, entire planets… Sometimes for resisting too much, sometimes because he thought it was the right thing to do. Sooner or later everyone met this fate.” he said, and there was a gloomy silence. Bina felt a cold sweat break out on her back. She had witnessed the annihilation of an entire planet, so she could imagine destruction on such a scale. However this was the Swarm, an unrestrained mindless force driven by an insatiable hunger, but here an intelligent being annihilated entire worlds because… He wanted it? Because it was his will? It was incomprehensible to her. She knew, though not personally, one person capable of such a thing, but even he ... But he was guided by logic, cold and ruthless. It was just madness. „Why did I go to this place cursed by devils and demons” she thought in horror. The others seemed to share her feelings. Arkantar scratched his cheek nervously, Itel stared at Wrongdak in disbelief, Lady Cala looked down sadly, Captain Moonshadow looked away. “She met the Wrongdak brothers, as did Dilayla.” she recognized him…though I don't think she was looking for him." Only Eti was ostentatiously unshaken. This was how she showed her emotions on normal days. By absolute peace. Wrongdak broke the silence. He pointed to two points on the holographic map.

„Icarus is here.” pointed to the first place, a star system located in a dense cluster of stars. "That's where my friends come from. Star siblings. After Horde Prime's death, they led a rebellion against him. Their planet was once the center of trade for the entire region. When he… When Horde Prime arrived there, it was all over. The inhabitants resisted and… they were punished. The destruction was… massive, but now they are rebuilding their

world. I was there for a few weeks and I have some friends there…. We can also fly to Anywhere…" he pointed to the second point, a moon near the gas giant. He smiled at their confused looks. "It was the place where the guerrillas and others who stood against him hid. Radiation from the moon interferes with most ships' sensors. But I'll show you how to calibrate yours."

They thought for a few moments. Bina spoke first.

„I choose Icarus. This seems to be the place we are used to. Radiation doesn't sound very appealing, and I've had some experience with the rebels, and they're not conclusive.

The rest of her nodded, only Captain Moonshadow added.

„Show my crew how to calibrate the sensors. This may come in handy someday."

Wrongdak nodded. Lady Cala had been inputting calculations on the mapping device throughout the clone story. Finally she said.

"I've mapped out a flight route for us, it will take us three weeks of drifting." With a bit of luck, of course, because Drift is unpredictable.

Bina looked at her in surprise.

„Are you familiar with drift navigation? she asked the aristocrat, who smiled and said.

„Yes, and also in biology, ancient art and many others. I have five faculties. I'm also a first-class swordsman and I'm licensed to pilot starships."

„And I thought you had six faculties. Ethi said suddenly.

„Six?" Lady Cala asked in surprise.

„You know, don't forget the most important thing, the modesty faculty". said the feline girl.

Good point

Wrondak was getting impatient during the drift flight. He had been on ships using this drive before, and it was always an extraordinary experience for him. He has traveled in hyperdrive ships like the Darla and time-bending Horde warships. But this was something else. The inhabitants of the Galaxy used combined magic and technology to travel through space. They found themselves in a different world, a plane connecting all dimensions, and they moved over huge distances. The drift was not empty, there were fragments of other worlds floating here. He knew the drive's technical specifications, though not knowing anything about magic, he couldn't understand everything, but he hoped Entrapta would enjoy it anyway... Maybe he'd even look at this ship. He could imagine her screams of excitement at the sight of this technology, and it warmed his heart. But he had other reasons for wanting to return to Etheria.

He wanted to reassure Glimmer with the news that the Galaxy was not a terrible graveyard of worlds ravaged by Horde Prime. But he also wanted them to meet his new friends. Especially these two. Eti had something of Catra about her. Not only in appearance, although they were similar. She… had something in her's heart. Anger, but with her it was deeply hidden. He knew Catra's past, not as well as the others, but he knew she had been badly hurt. Eti had pain in her as well, but another, much more familiar one, but he couldn't quite pinpoint what it was... But Lady Cala Grayskull was here too... She was beautiful and strong and wise. He had never met someone so extraordinary. And she said her ancestor was Mara, the previous She-Ra, a woman who, like Adora, was one of the First Ibes. This meant that the hero of Etheri was no longer alone, she was not the last of the First Ones They didn't look alike, but at the same time they looked a lot alike… *No, Lady Cala looks like She-Ra* he thought in surprise, and felt a hint of uneasiness in the back of his mind, but then it dissipated.

He felt good on this ship among all these people, so interesting and unusual. He liked to help with test alarms and system checks, cooking and cleaning, and he thought he had won the crew's sympathy, except for Eti, who continued to fuss at him and call him names from the Wormdak. He didn't mind, from Glimmer and Bow's stories, he knew it could be much worse.

Earlier in the observatory, he had not noticed it, but after one of the trainings Eti took off the glove. Then he saw her hand and maimed fingers. He looked away, trying not to stare, although the girl must have noticed it anyway, because she growled at him incomprehensibly. He saw that Miss Daisy was also looking at the girl in amazement and horror. But he doubted if she really understood how much this girl had lost. He knew suffering, and he knew how much pain some people can inflict on others for no reason, just for the sake of pleasure… E*vil did not go away with Horde Prime. Recently, I was able to convince myself of this*

As he thought about it, he felt something rubbing against his calves and arms. He turned around smiling broadly. He saw Toshi, the electric fox and mascot of the crew. He stroked his head, and the animal began to sniff him looking for something tasty, which is probably batteries. When he did not find them, he flew away and wrapped himself around the neck of Eti sitting on the bench. The girl gave Wrongdak a triumphant look.

„The pet seems to like you”. said Miss Daisy.

„He just likes intelligent creatures. Eti said, clenching and opening her mutilated hand.

"If my observations are correct, then Mr. Wrongdak is a person as smart as you ... only fulfilling in other fields." said Miss Daisy in a sonorous voice.

„Usually animals like me. At first I was a little afraid of them, as was of Emily, but now I like them… they are simpler than

intelligent beings. They hide less and are not as complex. Just like I understand Droids better than biological beings.” he said to both women.

- And and everything is right with Emily?” asked Miss Daiy, smiling at him.

„Okay... She's been a bit scared lately. This trip and what happened to us on Saltmarsh must have affected her badly.” The woman replied with a smile of her own.

- It's just a Dumbbot! Who would care?” Eti asked contemptuously.

"Emily is much smarter than anyone would have guessed…. She is a good friend who takes care of her friends on her own. Said the sorceress looking at the Droid, who was standing in the corner of the training room, who was staring at her very carefully. In fact, Emily seemed scared and anxious lately. Especially in the presence of a grim sorceress. He had seen the terrible power she possessed. The inhabitants of the galaxy practiced many kinds of magic, often very dark. The Bone Sages of Eox terrified him the most. It wasn't them that he feared, but the terrible prospect that their power offered them. There was nothing in the world he feared more than the return of Horde Prime. Miss Daisy also reminded him of someone terrible he had met a long time ago, but only for a moment. But she died on Etheri as did his Big Brother. He anxiously looked again at the dark sorceress, who watched with concern as Eti irritated the contracture in her hand. “She never showed us an iota of selfless concern. Not an iota of love. There's no point in remembering her," Catra once told him when he asked her about the masked sorceress.

„You mentioned your Older Brother.” Miss Daisy asked unexpectedly.

„Yes ... I am named after him ... in a sense ...” he replied, getting ready to do it again

„Rosie told me about it. What do you think is going on with him?” she asked in a slightly bored voice.

„He took up residence on the Beast Island a terrible place, to purify it... He said he did it to atone for his deeds. My friend joined him and they live there together.” he replied smiling to himself.

„Together?” the sullen woman asked, surprised, which was… surprising.

„Yes, before they met, my brother was completely lonely for many years, but now he has someone and a very close to one another.”

„Hmmm... Well, I'm the absolute last person to judge them.” A sad, mysterious smile appeared on Miss Daisy's face.

Hurt but unbroken

One of the most important skills of a soldier is the ability to cope with long periods of inactivity. Soldiers of the regular army were drilled, mercenaries wasted money on fun. Fortunately for everyone, Dilayla was different from her colleagues in this regard. Yes, she liked to drink and sometimes used the services of marquees, although she didn't have to very often, but she saved most of her money for ... not quite sure what, exactly ... Retirement? For a quiet life? She wasn't really sure what she could do outside of the fight. She could go to the temple of Iomadae, but she could always do that…. She was surprised to discover that she has no real purpose in life and just drifts where fate takes her. *I'm less than a leaf in the wind* she thought as she lay on her bunk and stared at the ceiling. The cabin was cramped. A two-story bed, narrow but comfortable, a micro bathroom, a cupboard. Not much, but it was a luxury compared to military barracks or sleeping in the open air. She spent most of her time in the common room or cargo hold anyway, going through their gear, though of course she couldn't see what Lady Cala and her *guardian* had brought with them. She must ask Arkan-tar about it, who should be interested in what the aristocrat took, or even talk to Bina, who should take care of it.

She shared a cabin with Wrongdak. She could have taken Rosie, but she was still stressed about being suspected of being her *sleeping bag friend* And besides, then Doctor Quin would be in the same cabin with Wrongdak. There would then be far too much of a resemblance that he would end up in multiple pieces in jars of formalin. The alien was a pleasant if silent companion. She wanted to ask him about his friends sometimes, but he still didn't trust her enough to fully open up. Looking at her traveling companions, she wasn't surprised. She herself did not trust them at all, and the Lord Admiral had in his eyes, or rather eye, a coldness that she had seen only in the eyes of the most ruthless commanders, and this did not bode well, although those around

him made her uneasy. Lady Ka looked like either a psychopath or a drug addict, and she was probably both. Lady Sorowflame… who sane would be called that?

However, she herself was not a very good conversationalist. Most of her stories were about her more or less heroic deeds during the war, and it wasn't something that some one who was being forced to be a soldier wanted to hear about. So she decided to tell him about her childhood and the good old days. However, she quickly realized that sooner or later her story would lead to the grim end that his big brother gave her family. So they spent time together in the cabin in silence, although there was not much of it ...

Back in Saltmarsh, she exchanged credits for hard currency, and bought some weapons, meds, and ammunition. She didn't know how long they would be in the ravaged zone, or what technology they had there.

Before leaving, Bina gave them a document to sign. In it, *Rules of peaceful coexistence with my crew* were written. She read the text carefully, she was a mercenary and knew how many traps a contract could contain, but she absolutely did not expect it. Because they had to accept extremely unusual rules.

“Eti is not a cat and has nothing to do with cats. This is an indisputable fact.”

"Lilka is an orc. It's an indisputable fact."

"Alatar is neither a small dragon nor a fat dragonkin"

"The Dragonkin Riders are a bullshit myth!"

"Eti doesn't purr. she growls"

"If Lilka says something is orcish, it is orcish even if it's jelly Skitermanders"

"We don't touch Alatar's nerdy stuff without asking"

"We don't touch Lilka's orc charms without asking.

"We don't touch maps and other Itel-owned equipment without asking"

"We do not touch Eti's weapons"

"We don't give Eti money"

"If one of the crew members takes some medicine, we don't investigate why"

"If any of the crew members are rude to you, let me know"

"We ignore the fact that Eti gives you new names, it's her quirk"

"Eti is an absolutely perfect, amazing and unique creature" (crossed out) "Eti be quiet!”

Wrongdak and Rosie read the document and signed it, eyeing the crew suspiciously. Lady Cala smiled understandingly. Miss Daisy laughed strangely. And Ysoka kept grumbling about not agreeing to it. Emily also got her copy signed by Wrondak. Dilayla thought for a moment. Had she not known who these young people were and how much they had been through, she would have snorted in amusement. But she understood that their quirks stemmed from how much their lives had hurt them. *They are hurt but not broken. Not broken by any means*

She liked these weird kids. They reminded her of herself. They were shaped by war and loss like the one she experienced. *At least I had a place to go back to. They are alone in this cold universe at the mercy of the gods…* she thought as she sat on a chair and watched them play some board game. Lilka, with glasses on her nose, looked bizarre, but also charming, she read the instructions aloud, because everyone remembered the rules differently. For the last half hour they had been arguing and shouting instead of playing. Rosie watched them confused, her glasses unable to cope with a group of shouting teenagers. When

no one was looking, Eti tried to move the pawns with her tail, but as soon as someone noticed...

"I am not cheating. It's just that my tail and this pawn ended up in exactly the same place, and I refuse to let my tail's freedom be limited by a soulless piece of plastic, so it has been moved to a place that only by chance is favorable to me, but you of course you have to make contrived and absolutely baseless accusations because you can't accept losing." said the feline girl in this strange monotonous voice, while gently moving another pawn. Itel and Alatar looked at her with narrowed eyes, and Lilka continued to read the instructions aloud. Rosie was moving the pawn back to its place. Dilayla smiled at the sight. Now they were almost normal kids, albeit quite unruly. But she saw their morning "Prayers"

"Teeth for Offense"

"Tongue for a Lie"

"Hand for Punch"

"Eyes for an Eye"

"Heart for Betrayal"

Then she realized how much they had been hurt by the world and life. Itel, Alatar and Lilka, like most children of war like them, tried to hide their fear and pain behind a mask of bravado and aggressiveness. And Eti, that was another story. The girl, judging by her accent, came from the same place as Bina, which was the planet Atrax, which was, as far as she knew, in the same system as Kesler, which was the home of the other three young people, which was destroyed by the swarm. But sometimes her Absalom accent kicked in, like a moment ago when she was arguing about a moved pawn. In addition, Wrongdak claimed that she resembled his friend, if she understood correctly. She didn't want to be nosy, so she didn't question the white-skinned alien, but from the context she inferred that she might have come from Etheria... Did

that apply to this girl as well? It just didn't make sense… How could she hide such important information among such a close-knit group? Unless they were all somehow connected to that planet and fulfilling some important mission for its authorities. A mission unsettlingly similar to the one they were on... If so, they're lost... Shouldn't she tell the others? She looked at Miss Daisy. The woman was writing down something while looking at what was displayed on her screen, but she was also listening to the kids' conversation all the time. *I'm not sure I should warn people like them* she thought with a wry smile. The crew of this ship definitely didn't look like sneaky spies or conspirators... Wrongdak could be wrong, after all, he himself said that he was a very young clone, and the education that this Horde Prime had given them didn't make life in society any easier. There were only two more problems. The feline girl, Eti, had a goddamn artifact prosthetic, and the captain of the ship looked like Lady Ka, which she wouldn't have cared much about if the woman in the half-mask didn't look like a fucker. People like her were dangerous as opponents, because they were absolutely unpredictable, but also as allies, because they didn't care that because their wonderful ideas, outsiders or allies would get hurt. "I'm just a trigger, do I have to deal with solving mysteries? Why wasn't bloody Verthani in my place? Or Mean Ysoka?"

Miss Daisy, meanwhile, went over to the game table, looked at the board, and took Rosie's piece and moved it. Itel stood up and looked at the situation on the board and said in disbelief.

„It's a good move... you actually reversed the situation on the board...”

The grim elf nodded and said.

"It's largely thanks to Miss Rosie." I just took advantage of an opportunity she may have missed.

"You didn't look like the kind who could…play games," Dragonkin asked in surprise. Miss Daisy smiled… nostalgically.

„Yes, although I know mainly the old ones, although I have learned a few in the meantime. For my previous employer, playing strategy games was one of the few distractions he allowed himself.”

This time the kids looked at her with some appreciation, although the green-haired elf seemed a bit suspicious.

„Do you know the game of river kings ...” Eti asked curiously. Miss Daisy nodded.

„Yes, although it was called a bit differently here... Princesses of rivers or control of waterways when I played with my employer. I also know a mandala, go... clash...” she mentioned the names of subsequent games so ancient that the place where they were created was no longer known.

"And you know how to play When the Horde Comes?" Lilka interjected. Miss Daisy looked at her in surprise.

„No, but I can learn. I also have a feeling that my former employer would like it.” she said in a thoughtful voice.

What are you up to? thought Dilayla, looking at the dark sorceress.

She was even more disturbed by what happened the next day. They were in the training room where Itel and Lilka were practicing fencing. The Solarian was extremely agile, and the red-haired girl attacked with a fury worthy of an orc of ancient legend, not one of those modern half-slaves. Dilayla liked to come here. As a kid, she was on the youth boxing team. Her first girlfriend was also member. They even won a local championship. She was so proud of herself then… now she could bludgeon someone to death with little effort, and in power armor she could tear apart a tank. "How much I've changed since then, how much innocence we've all lost." She thought, realizing how much she was like those kids. *Only I got my revenge, They will have to wait a little*

longer. Whoever Horde Prime was, he was but one mortal being, and the Swarm is pure hunger, no one and nothing will satiate it

Itel deftly parried Lilka's next attacks, until finally the pissed redhead growled and grabbed her wrist, but then the elf cut her. The pseudo-ork girl screamed and dragged the elf to the floor, and the two girls began to struggle. Bina, who was standing in the corner of the room, approached them and began to separate them.

"Cam down, or you'll end up in Mr. Ilemshaw's infirmary!" she screamed.

"I don't think there's any reason to intervene. Previous incidents of this type, and I must say there have been many, have never resulted in any significant injury." Said a voice coming from the boom camera. It was Mr. Ilemshaw, a strange fish-like creature that lived in a large aquarium in the laboratory, cybernetically connected to the ship's various systems. He was weird and a little unsettling, but since she'd woken up with her cybernetic prosthetics, she found all the doctors unsettling.

„There were many of them, you say, it's so funy". Bina said coldly, staring at the camera and wagging her finger. At this time, the girls got up and, as if nothing had happened, talked about the fight, going to the training equipment. Then Lady Cala entered the Training Room and Dilayla's mood dropped. *The last person I want to see* Unfortunately, the lovely aristocrat spent a lot of time training. "Somewhere she must have gotten fit enough to run from the city to the observatory in less than two hours." Miss Daisy followed her like a shadow. Rosie, who was training by the punching bag, greeted the two women happily, but Eti, standing at the virtual shooting range, took off her goggles and stared murderously at the aristocrat. The girl has a nose, you have to give her that, thought Dilayla, smiling coldly. Lilka and Itel broke away from their exercises and bowed to Lady Cala and her guardian.

„I can never get over what a great training room you have created. It surpasses ours in Castle Grayskull in every way.” said the aristocrat, smiling warmly. Itel nodded, pretending she didn't care, but it was clear that her ego was boosted by the noblewoman's praise.

„Do you have any plans for raining session today?” said the solarian, Eti almost smiled and said.

„I propose to be a living target.”

The aristocrat ostentatiously ignored her and turned to the green-haired Elf.

"I'd love to train with you if it's not a problem and your captain agrees." Lady Cala asked, and Bina thought for a moment. The aristocrat began to put on training clothes, and then Dilayla approached the captain and asked her.

"You're not afraid that it might end badly.

„It will end badly for sure... But what are you asking about?” replied the woman with burgundy hair and laughed unhappily.

„Well, training with the wonderful Lady Cala.” The mercenary answered, a bit surprised.

"Oh, it's happened to her twice already, and nothing bad has come of it.Even Itel isn't offended by losing and doesn't get paranoid. I've known this kids for five years, you can even say half of my life, they even liked you. Especially Rosie became friends with my gang. That's the only thing that can cause problems.”

Dilayla raised eyebrow.

„What do you mean.”

Bina sighed heavily.

„Alatar "likes" Itel. Itel "likes", Eti, and I have a feeling Eti is starting to "like" Rosie.” the captain of the ship explained to the mercenary. The way she said likes made it clear what kind of relationship she meant. *Such shoes. I need to talk to Rosie. This girl may not realize what a feline girl might want from her. At best, it can be an embarrassingly awkward situation ... But Eti was so ... specific that it could have ended badly.*

The girls stood in the ring. Both had holographic weapons attached to their training suits so that they emulated weight, and the vests themselves reacted to the blows they received, inducing slight pain. A very ingenious and useful device. Itel was armed with an equivalent of her Solarian blade, and Lady Cala carried a epee. The first exchange of blows was lightning fast. After the elf's aggressive attack, the noblewoman made a feint, winning the round. It was then up to Itel to adopt a defensive strategy, but the extremely fast attacks pierced the solarian's veil. Lady Cala then asked Lilka to join the fight as well. The red-haired warrior gladly agreed and this time the fight lasted a bit longer. But when Itel almost collided with Lilka, the aristocrat launched two lightning attacks and won for the third time. Only the last clash was more even and several times each side was close to losing. Finally, Lady Cala fell for Itel's feint and got hit. The elf, all wet from the effort, smiled triumphantly.

„She's good”. Bina said they are looking at Lady Cali. Dilayla shook her head.

"No, she's the absolute best swordswoman I've ever seen, and I trained in the Order of the Eclipse, so I've seen some really great fighters."

"You wanted to be a hellknight?" You don't look like that. asked the surprised captain.

„No, they took us in, me and my sister, after the dammed Horde ravaged Minitar. They really aren't as bad as they say. The lictor saved us and adopted Asindesa di Vir, she is also from our planet ..." *But he covered her, not me or my sister* she thought bitterly.

“Back to Lady Cali, she wins easily, but she loses by a hair, so you know.

"Are you suggesting she let herself be defeated?" Bina asked, and the mercenary answered her with a nod.

„Lady Cala... Can I train with you too?” Rosie asked, blushing.

"Of course not, Sparkle Hand. Then you'll smell like her and I won't be able to stand you.” Eti said indignantly.

"There really is something going on" thought the mercenary anxiously.

„Of course... How do you fight?” asked Lady Cala, smiling warmly.

„I can fight hand-to-hand, and I think I'm pretty good at it.” Rosie signed.

„You're awesome, Sparkle hand. You'll kick her noble ass. „ said Eti, and the white-haired girl blushed.

„Maybe. In hand-to-hand combat, I'm a bit worse. said the Aristocrat. Rosie took off her glasses and gloves so they wouldn't get damaged and faced Lady Cali, who assumed a combative stance. Aristocrat landed a few lightning strikes, which, however, were blocked and Rosie countered, which pushed Cala almost to the mat. The noblewoman was surprised by such resistance, but before she could do anything, the white-haired girl attacked her. Rosie's hands began to glow brightly. Dilayla had never expected such aggression from an intern. Nobleborn tried to kick Rosie, but Rosie grabbed her and knocked her to the mat. Lady Cala freed her leg by bending the knee at a very strange angle and began furiously attacking the white-haired girl with great force, whose eyes began to glow with a strange inner glow. Some of Lady Cala’s punches, like splayed sideways strikes aimed at the throat, could kill. Dilayla was already moving towards the combatants to stop the clash, but then Rosie hit the noble so powerfully that she flew to the other end of the room and slammed into the wall. For a moment the intern looked like she was about to lunge at Lady

Cali and finish her off with one mighty blow, but then she shook her head and realized what she had done. Terrified, with tears in her eyes, she ran to the noble and tried to ask in sign language, but she had no gloves, so no one understood her. Dilayla herself approached the wounded woman, expecting the worst. The others in the training room did the same, though Miss Daisy did not look frightened. Lady Cala, however, immediately began to rise, and for a moment it seemed to the mercenary that a grimace of indescribable fury appeared on the face of the aristocrat, but after a moment it disappeared, replaced by a painful smile.

„Don't worry, I'm fine. I'll just need a day or two to rest in my cabin.” she patted Rosie head. The girl was rubbing her red eyes now. Eti put her hand on her shoulder, the living and biological one, and almost smiled reassuringly.

"Are you sure you don't want to go to the infirmary? The hit looked really scary.” Mr. Ilemshaw asked.

„No, I'm fine. Those bearing the mark of Grayskull are not so easy to break.” she smiled at the boom camera.

„It is not easy to break you. indeed „. said Miss Daisy

The sins of your brothers

They flew through the drift and Rosie felt happier than ever. She finally found friends who liked her. Even the itel, who at first looked at her like a Warg, after a few days won over to her. They played games, they trained, and she tried to help with the drill alarms, though she wasn't always successful, she wasn't a technician, and she didn't know how the ship worked. But she knew that no matter what she did, she would never quite be one of them. They had something in common that he would never fully understand. Alatar was always nervously checking that all the ship's security features were active. Lilka had to sleep with the light on, and Itel spent hours studying the reports of activity of the Swarm, but also other things she didn't fully understand. And then there was Eti, a strange Feline girl, so different from her, and at the same time she felt that she was very close to her. She couldn't understand why, but it was...

Days passed, full of pleasant routine. Even helping Dr. Quin didn't bother her, but Ysoka seemed preoccupied with her work, though she also had the impression that she was somehow frightened. After training with Lady Cala, she was ashamed to leave her cabin, fearing others would accuse her of hurting the aristocrat. She really didn't want to do it. Just after the first exchange of blows, she suddenly awoke to see Lady Cala lying against the wall. She was afraid that she had murdered an noblewoman, and she didn't even know how she had done it. This had never happened to her before, even when she beat up the one who was picking on her, she didn't lose her consciousness. “Does it have anything to do with me forgetting who I am? Did I do something so terrible that I didn't want to remember it?" she thought. Dilayla was amazed and Eti delighted with her display of skill. Even Itel had stopped looking at her indulgently, now she was only suspicious. It terrified her. She promised herself that she wouldn't fight in training anymore. She would love to never fight anyone

again, but she was aware that during such an expedition it might be impossible.

Fortunately, Lady Cala didn't hold it against her. She was such a good person full of compassion and mercy, so it was no wonder that she forgave her. After all, she had hired Miss Daisy despite her dark past and had treated her like a member of the family, almost like a mother. Rosie, after that night confession, felt strange in the company of a dark sorceress. That woman did something very terrible, summoned a creature from the darkness that not only scarred her face, but changed it in a terrible way. She also knew that this was only part of her story, that the worst she hadn't told her anyway. Whenever she was around a dark elf, she wanted to assure her that she would not reveal her secret to anyone. In fact, she wasn't sure if the woman cared. She was gloomy and very resigned. When she wasn't with Lady Cala or teaching the young crew members, she was copying drawings of some flowers. At that time, Ireanis, this not so talented, but very cheerful elven sorceress, tried to befriend her. At first Miss Daisy wasn't very polite in rejecting her, but Ireanis was stubborn and eventually started bringing in some liquor that seemed to be made in a laboratory. Seeing this, Miss Daisy murmured softly.

„Good old moonshine from the technical department.” she laughed bitterly.

Rosie didn't like the gloomy woman drinking so much. Even less so that she usually did it surreptitiously when no one was looking. But she didn't know what she could do. She wanted to talk to someone about it. Maybe with Lady Cala? But she was ashamed to speak to the aristocrat after what she had done to her. Maybe will ask Eti. She was pretty sure that the other girl had been eavesdropping on her conversation with Miss Daisy, so that wouldn't amount to revealing a secret, would it?

The drift flight was weird. She had always felt better than anyone else the tremors of all the ship's mechanisms. In this strange magical place, however, everything vibrated completely differently. Normally she had trouble falling asleep due to the vibrations, but

in the drift she felt calm, as if she were at home, in a familiar and safe place. She wondered where it was coming from, maybe before… before she got lost, she traveled a lot through space? Though some said that her capsule may have come from before the discovery of drift. She didn't understand much of it.

They arrived at the first planet three days after leaving Saltmarsh. They went above its orbit and began scanning it. On the bridge screen, they saw an ordinary planet covered mostly with blue oceans and a few greenish-brown lands.

"Alatar, are there any signs of life there? Inteligent one?" Bina asked him.

"No, I can't see anything..." Dragonkin replied. But then Arkan-tar instructed him to enter some new parameters that would detect if there were cities here and plot it on the map, which immediately turned red, indicating the remains of ancient settlements. Everyone stared at the map in disbelief, except for Wrongdak, who looked down sadly.

„I told you there's nothing there. That you will find only death here..." said the white-skinned alien.

„Judging by the degree of urbanization and the amount of radioactive elements and it must have been an advanced space civilization, albeit without interplanetary travel abilities. About three billion people lived there." Verthani's voice sounded exaggeratedly formal.

„Nobody survived?" Bina asked in a voice full of horror.

„No one technologically advanced, although perhaps someone is hiding in the wilds. However, they have lost their entire technological base, and recreating civilization will be much more difficult due to the lack of readily available resources such as coal and oil." Ilemshaw said. Silence fell. Rosie walked over to Wrongdak and took his hand to comfort him.

"Nothing... We're moving on," said Bina.

The next few days passed in a slightly more nervous atmosphere. Everyone tried to behave as before, but it was not possible. Arkan-tar was exaggeratedly cheerful, and Rechiza was darkly thoughtful. The young crew members tried to show off that they didn't care about the discovery of the ravaged planet, but she knew it must have been a shock to them. Especially itel, who seemed to feel guilty about getting everyone on this journey. When Bina passed by her, she looked away. The captain of the ship seemed concerned about what they encountered. Dilayla became very protective of her and Wrongdak. She tried to encourage them to train and spend time with the rest of the crew. She liked the mercenary, she was protective of her like a sister. She said she used to have a sister, but she lost her to Horde invasion. She wasn't entirely sure, but she didn't think he was telling her the whole truth. But she was brave and strong, although for unknown reasons she did not like Lady Cala ... But fortunately she made friends with Wrondak, who now needs so much support and help. He seemed to feel guilty about what his brother had done…this Horde Prime. She couldn't imagine someone so evil. Eti once asked this, and she looked away and said.

"I've known a few similar… or almost as bad. One was Binah's father, Jantar, and the other... The former ruler of a certain planet. He... dropped bombs on his own people... Never mind, she said in a strangely gloomy mood.

Four days later they reached another planet. It once seemed to be more technologically advanced than the previous one, but even then it was almost completely devastated. But they managed to pick up one message.

„This is shelter two hundred and thirty-two. We're probably the last one. Our planet got attacked by the Galactic Horde. They defeated us and enslaved. Horde Prime, its only ruler, promised us peace and mercy, but gave us only suffering. And then, after twenty years, they decided to destroy us. For no reason. We were

simply deemed unworthy of the Light of Horde Prime. That we belong to the dark. He killed everything he didn't take. Hundreds of thousands went with him, chipped. We're hiding in an old shelter, but we're running low on supplies. We don't know if we'll survive outside. If anyone can hear us, please help us. And by no means trust Horde Pime. Everything he says is lies. Everything." and then the message looped.

Everyone looked at Bina with a silent question. The captain, however, closed her eyes and said.

„It's an old transmission. There's probably no one there. But you know, nature has rebuilt itself. Birds are chirping, fish are splashing. It's fucking awesome". she said firmly. Wrongdak hid in the shadows as if it were his fault.

„I... I'm so sorry. So much."

Then Lady Cala smiled softly at him.

„It's not your fault. No one can be held responsible for the deeds of his brothers." Dilayla, Eti and, surprisingly, Miss Daisy looked at the aristocrat suspiciously.

"Indeed, you are not responsible for the sins of your brothers."

They reached the next planet three days later. This time Rosie felt the atmosphere on the bridge was grave. Everyone already knew what awaited them here.

„I detected activity on the planet. There's some small power source there, some kind of outpost, a survivors' shelter. I turn on. Dragonkin said.

„No, do not do that!" the white-skinned alien shouted, but Alatar triggered the signal.

„Do not be afraid. Embrace the light of Horde Prime. Until now, you have lived in the darkness to which your wicked leaders and false gods have condemned you. But Horde Prime's mercy knows no bounds. Receive his light. Renounce darkness. Open your minds to his truth. He will drive the shadows away. Cast out Shadows! Horde Prime sees everything. Horde Prime knows everything.” and this message also looped. Everyone was silent for a moment in consternation. Finally, Arkan-tar broke the silence.

"Does it seem right to me, didn't he speak in Wrongdak's voice?"

Dilayla nodded and said.

„They're clones. Why are you surprised. It not Wrongdak fault. Oh gods That Prime was talking same bullshit to us, on the Minitar.

Bina shuddered.

„This fucker was talking bigger shit than my father, who was a bit of a crazy son of a bitch.” she said and laughed uneasily.

„Please… - Wrongdak said, and everyone jumped. They looked at the stranger, who was kneeling. Emily was hugging him. Streams of tears ran down his face. - don't turn it on again. I don't want to hear his voice. Never again…”

She played Clash with Eti and was impressed with the girl's skills. She has been fond of playing games since she was a child. Even in the Isles of Sorrow, the ability to play Go was highly prized. She always outplayed her sisters. Stormheart was never smart enough, and Midnight Mask was always too confident to win with her. They hated her for it, as for many other things, though the time for real hatred came later. In Mystacor, it was an important element of social life. Over the tables soteric mysteries were discussed, alliances and friendships were made, and positions plotted, and in her day the struggle for office was ruthless, or so it seemed to her. But for her, it was also about feeling triumphant. She has always loved competition, fighting for victory and seeing

her rival defeated. She wanted to feel better, stronger than her rivals… Until she finally started playing the real game, where real beings were mepples and life or death was at stake. But even in the Fright Zone, she didn't deny herself this pastime. It wasn't hard to convince Hordak to introduce board games as one of the training elements. She was supported by the Usurper King and his daughter, so she got the right funds without any problems. The king's granddaughter was one of the first cadets she tried this training method on, though of course the old king didn't live to see that moment...

She has had many partners at the table since then. Hordak was a good player, but he was easily angered and hated to lose, though of course he always hid that fact. Scorpia only liked to play to be with others. She wasn't interested in the game, but the players. She quickly decided that paying attention to her was a waste of her precious time. And then it was Adora and Catra's turn, so the Scorpion princess was completely put aside. Adora… she always did everything with absolute focus and dedication. She even played board games as if she were carrying out some extremely important mission, the success of which depended on the happiness of her friends ... Actually, she wasn't too wrong. Catra was often scolded for Adora's failures. Unlike her *Best Friend*, she hated to play. Now, after all these years, she realized it was her fault. When she wanted to, she could be a great teacher, demanding but also understanding, able to bring out the best in students. Oh yes, when she wanted to. For Catra, she had nothing but anger and contempt. She couldn't find the patience to explain to this lively young girl how to play properly and enjoy it. Catra had always felt constrained by rules and regulations that hampered her clever mind. At the time, she believed that her charge was simply too lazy to impose the discipline needed to develop her strategic skills. But she knew that when she played cards, she could outplay anyone. Wasn't that a signal that her charge hid much more than she could see in her? Twice she made the mistake of letting her conceit and contempt obscure the truth about her students. He won't make the same mistake this time.

Eti was something else. She was undoubtedly of high intellect and liked to plan strategically. Like Hordak, she was better at abstract and context-free games, but unlike the former self-proclaimed ruler of Etheria, she was able to think outside the box and didn't get angry whenever things didn't go her way on the board. She was absolutely focused on the game and sometimes felt that the more the girl let herself be consumed by the competition, the more her personality changed. She becomes colder and more determined. It bothered her, but more and more things about this girl were a mystery to her. Starting from her hand. At first she thought it was just a rather unusual prosthetic, possibly magical. But this was an artifact of the First Ones that was, all too literally, in the hands of a teenage girl. It reminded her all too well of the sword that Adora had found… that had called her to become a tool and a weapon… Who was this girl going to become. *The Punishing Hand. It sounds ominous, and yet the First Ones liked beautiful-sounding euphemisms, didn't they, Light Hope?* she thought as she took down the spearman. They played Clash in variant what the girl called "Old Kingdom Rules," which made the game more dynamic and aggressive. It was an interesting variation, because the slower variations of this game. Then Eti beat her rider.

„Nice move. And clever.” She praised her.

„As painful as it is, sometimes the sacrifice of individuals is necessary to protect the majority”. Eti said in her calm, slightly colorless voice. She frowned upon hearing that sentence. It didn't suit her. It sounded like she was quoting someone. It happened to her sometimes, , she spoke then as educated, or at least pretended to be. Just… why? Usually the girl behaved like someone brought up on the street, or even in the wild. She was like the poor kids she'd oversaw in the Fright Zone, but wilder and more untamed. *Just like Catra... Just like her sister.* She started using the word in her mind in relations to the girl. It seemed very appropriate, after all, they were so similar ... *But also different. Catra was like a pyre flame, so hot it could incinerate anything it touched. But such embers quickly burn out, leaving only black ashes. Eti was a cold flame, glowing blue like sparks in her eyes.*

An icy fire that kills all life. Why do these thoughts come to my mind? What's happening here?

And these words. Once upon a time she would have agreed with them, but now? After everything she's been through? After the suffering and despair she has condemned others to in the name of her dark desires and ambitions... Never more…

„Miss Daisy? They're calling you to the bridge. Rosie said smiling. She shook her head, trying to get out of these strange thoughts.

„I'm coming. Later we will finish the game Eti.” she asked the feline girl, who also started to get up.

"I'm comming to, Sparkle hand. I hope now we will vote whether we throw Odora through the airlock." said Eti cheerfully, and the white-haired girl rolled her eyes. She liked Rosie and was glad that the two girls liked each other. It is a pity that the deaf woman had such sympathy for Lady Cala, unfortunately, she could not warn her of the danger her "ward" was.

She regretted her honesty that time on the roof, but after hearing what fate befell Angela, she just had to get drunk. Rosie started treating her differently from then on, but to her surprise, she didn't push her away, and even seemed to sympathize with her. It was so ridiculous that she wanted to shout to the girl what a monster she was. But she knew that if Rosie found out, she would hate her. And rightly so, because she deserved nothing else,

The white-haired girl also seemed to be hiding a secret. She had defeated Lady Cala in hand-to-hand combat, and even if only because she surprised her ward, it was an incredible feat. She could only hope Lady Cala didn't want revenge, because there was nothing she could do about it.

On the bridge were Bina, Arkan-tar, Alatar, Lady Cala and Wrondak, who seemed to be downcast. At first she hated him, if only because he reminded her of Hordak. But he was so different from him that she simply couldn't hate him the way she hated her

former superior, and after what had happened to him after listening to Horde Prime's insane speech, she felt genuinely sorry for him. *You have become weak and soft Shadow Weaver, and you must be stronger than ever before. For Catra and Adora… For Mikah and Glimmer… For Asindesa.* she chided herself mentally.

Angela's face appeared on the screen… No, Captain Moonshadow face. She looked away because she didn't want to see what had happened to the former queen. Who she has become.

„Hello, my dear. We just came out of the drift and picked up a signal that should be of interest to you."

Wrongdak tensed, and Bina covered her face with her hand.

"Just please don't let this be any more of that Prime light crap or my vein will burst." The woman with burgundy hair grunted.

"It's… something a bit different." Much fresher. My navigation and communications specialist says it's no more than a year old."

A genuine and happy smile appeared on Wrongdak's face. She herself had to put in a lot of effort to keep an impassive face. She guessed they both expected to see more or less the same thing.

„Okay, come on." Bina said with a sigh.

Both she and Wrongdak received something they absolutely did not expect.

A Drow woman dressed in costly red robes with the golden symbol of the Horde appeared on the screen. She held a long silver-and-gold staff with a bat-wing symbol at the end. Her surroundings were shrouded in shadow. She raised her cane and spoke softly, with sadness in her voice.

„We live in an age of darkness."

She moved aside and their eyes revealed the body of a clone, with three eyes on one side, lying on his back, covering the wound in

his chest with his hands. Above him loomed a silhouette half-shadowed in crimson, a great sword in his hand.

„Our Lord, Great Horde Prime was... murdered.” The drow's voice broke and tears streamed down her cheeks. “He sacrificed his life to prevent the Lady of Chaos from using a terrible weapon that would kill us all.” then the body flashed with a bright light pushing away the ominous silhouette. The animation was static, but clearly emphasized the message

„His light shone upon all who had faith in their hearts.” the previous scene disappeared and another image appeared before their eyes, this time it showed a clone in gold red robes, whose face was covered with scars. Behind him hovered the half-transparent form of Horde Prime, its glow illuminating the clone.

„Horde Ultimate became his chosen one. It was upon him that the essence of his radiance flowed… his spark. But not only on him.” Lines of other clones appeared around the Horde Ultimate, the farther away they were, the more modestly dressed. Farther still were members of the other races, all bearing the new golden symbol of the Horde.

„Anyone who feels its glow in the heart can prove it by faithful service and devotion. It doesn't matter if they are older or younger brothers, closer or more distant cousins. Each of you can carry the light of Horde Prime within you just like his chosen one and the prophet of Horde Ultimate. We must stand together united not only against heretics and traitors, but also against the forces of chaos that, though weakened by our Lord's sacrifice, still lie in wait to...

The previous image disappeared, and more figures began to appear. Their silhouettes were shrouded in black, crimson, and purple, their faces hidden in shadow. The first was a woman with mauve-pink hair, her face contorted into a ghostly smile, her hand burning with purple flame. Beside her stood a hunched, man with murderous look.

„Beware of the Witch Queen, whose dark magic brings death, and her Huntsman, who will rip out your hearts and bring them to his mistress to devour.”

Then a long-haired woman appeared, surrounded by thorny vines, blood was dripping from the thorns. Next to it stood a huge creature with pincers, shrouded in electrical discharges.

„Beware of the Lady of Thorns, who will nourish her gardens with your dead bodies. Beware the Lady of Thunder, whose unbridled rage brings death and destruction.

Then a white-haired woman in armor appeared, holding a spear and a steel net with spikes in her hands. A pink-haired woman appeared next to her, razor-sharp bits of obsidian and bits of metal circling around her.

„Beware of the Lady of War, whose cunning mind only seeks to thwart our efforts to bring peace to the galaxy, and beware of the Lady of Storm ready to strip your bones from your flesh and turn your land into a wasteland.

Then there was a woman holding a trident floating on a spiral made of black water, and beside her stood a man holding a torch and smiling madly.

„Beware the Lady of the Dark Waters! She will drown with polluted waters what her lover the Marauder will not plunder and incinerate.”

Then a strange female appeared, with tentacles growing from her head, and at her feet knelt a clone with red eyes and clumsy mechanical limbs. Beside it stood a monstrosity made of ice, blood, and stone.

„Beware of the mind eater who seeks to turn you into cybernetic nightmares as she did the Fallen, the villain whose betrayal nearly enabled our enemies to win. Beware of the Ice Bane that will freeze your blood to ice... But above all...”

Now a figure towering above all appeared. A woman with long fiery hair who wielded a blood-dripping sword in her hand. She rode a death-pale steed, and by her side on four legs stood a monstrosity resembling a hybrid of man and cat. He had one golden eye and one blue eye.

„Beware of the Lady of Chaos, who rides a palehorse, beside whom the Shadow Beast walks and Hell follows them."

The figures disappeared and the drow reappeared.

"Remember, you are the light of Horde Prime. We must all unite around Horde Ultimate together. Let our light cast out shadow."

The communiqué ended and everyone digested it in silence. Wrongdak stood with an extremely dumb face, but she had no doubt that she looked not much better. *It was good, way better than anything I've come up with* Alatar broke the silence.

„Eti, this Shadow Beast will start to compete with you." Dragonkin said.

The feline girl snorted.

„Draky, you must have too many teeth." she growled strangely gloomy. Concerned, Bina glanced at the girl.

"It's… it's all lies." There is no Horde Prime glow. He's gone and there's nothing left of him. They… My brothers. Everyone can be free." cried the pale-faced stranger.

„Some people are so afraid of freedom that they would rather die for the one who enslaved them. I know something about that." – said Bina

„The war is not only about territories and resources, but also about hearts and minds. If you get them, victory is yours." Eti said in a strange, not her voice.

Yes, neither you, Hordak, nor I, nor even Horde Prime could understand it. War is not only not converted obedient soldiers. Truth and Lies can also be weapons. She looked at Lady Cala, who was staring curiously at Wrongdak. *Especially a Beautiful Lies*

The light is darkening, the night is coming.

This was absolutely not where he wanted to be. Actually, there were plenty of places on Etheria he didn't want to be, far more than places he wanted to be. The way he was looking at his life, he was almost never where he really wanted to be. The Fright Zone, The Crimson Wastes, Castle Crypto…. In the latter, even Entrapta did not want to live and preferred to go to the Beast Island. He shuddered, that was also where they could go, considering how determined Lonnie was to get Hordak. Though, of course, she cared much more about Catra. This has been going on since they were kids. They hated each other then. It was difficult. Everyone admired Adora, wanted to be her friends. Well, they adored her. She…was nice to everyone, hardly even teasing him. But anyway, Catra, her beloved friend, always came first… Now she is simply her beloved. How strange it all is...

„Kyle, could you hurry up!" Lonnie yelled at him. They were in the northern reaches, one of the most inhospitable and desolate areas of Etheria. It was said to be a haunted land full of ghosts and shades. Shadow Weaver always told them there were no ghosts, but it was Shadow Weaer who sent her shadows to spy her enemies and rivals... Shesupposedly even stalked Adora that way.... Catra once brought an artifact from here with Entrapta and Scorpia. Soon after, of course, she sent Entrapta to the Isle of Beasts, and then everything fell apart.

„Comrade Kyle, you could at least focus on the mission instead of dreaming." His friend stood in front of him, glaring at him. She was beautiful even when she was angry with him. With Rogelio they always knew that. The reptile was now unloading crates full of equipment. They had two big little two-man off-road vehicles that had been made back when Catra had wanted to excavate here and look for ancient treasures… Hadn't she and Entrapta dug up some monsters too?

They were on the shore on a rocky beach, with the tundra dotted with blue-violet vegetation all around it, it was quite nice here if you think about it.

„You know, Lonnie, maybe it'll be nice here.” he said, trying to properly tie the packages to the trunk of the vehicle, although he was not very successful at it.

„We're not on a trip. It's not going to be nice here. We have an important job to do!” she growled at him.

He smiled friendly.

„That doesn't mean it can't be fun. I got marshmallows, sausages, banjo.” He said pointing to the packages.

„Banjo?” she asked incredulously, as if hearing the word for the first time.

„Well, when we build a fire, we'll cook sausages and marshmallows, and I'll play the banjo. This highlander, you know, the one-eyed one, taught me how to play and said I was pretty good.”

The woman's eyelid twitched for a moment.

„Kyle, we're not baking any marshmallows on any bonfire. One, it's damn cold here at night, two, we're in enemy territory, and three, HOW ARE YOU GOING TO MAKE A FIRE SINCE THERE'S NO TREES WITHIN 1,000 KILOMETERS.” She waved her hand, pointing to the endless plain stretching all around. He said with delight.

„So there are no enemies. And we can bake on these portable stoves.”

She underestimated his enthusiasm, for she shrieked, then turned sharply to Octavia, who stood proudly in the bow of the gunboat.

"Could your sailors, by their grace, tighten up and help Rogelio more."

The octopi-woman only after a moment turned very slowly towards her.

„Comrade Admiral Oktawia reports that, for fear of maintaining the morale of the crew on appropriate level, she cannot force her to be more intensively involved in unloading. „The one-eyed woman informed in a cool tone. She was Scorpia's age, but unlike the scorpion princess, she didn't like hugging her friends... Actually, she didn't like anyone, including Lonnie. It had been since Catra had taken her eye. I guess it was just her dislike of Catra that made her work for the Comrade General. They didn't have many ships because most of them either sanked by Mermista or destroyed Horde Prme. Only a handful survived, and only a few were held by the People's Rebellion. They came here by subterranean rivers, and then by the swampy river Mudribbon. It was a terrible place full of mosquitoes and strange predatory reptiles… *Not that I have anything against reptiles.* he smiled as he looked at Rogelio's muscular frame. *Oh, and there are no damned ones here...* He heard a shrill buzz and felt a prick on his cheek. He hit himself, but it was too late. He saw blood on his fingers.

„Lonnie, have you ever wondered if Shadow Weaver was bitten by mosquitoes?" he asked, finally strapping the package to the vehicle. Lonnie and Scarlet, who was standing next to her, gave him looks as if wondering if he was crazy.

"Kyle, I'm not thinking about our crazy… our fucking lead officer at all, and certainly not about whether or not the bugs liked her." And besides, do you remember what I told you? There were cockroaches and spiders and earwigs in the Fright Zone, but no damn bees or mosquitoes.

He thought.

“I remember when Catra put earwigs in your bed. You woke up the whole ward with your screams... It must have been after you told Adora that the earwigs enter the ears at night and puncture the eardrums. She couldn't sleep for two nights because of it. Me too... I guess I won't be able to sleep tonight either. And then Shadow Weaver said it was a stupid idea, and that where she came from, there are slimes that can come in through our noses at night and take over us... "We all couldn't sleep then. After two days, even you and Catra weren't growling at each other and you even fell asleep with your head on her shoulder."

Lonnie flinched when he mentioned pinches. She clearly didn't like the memory.

„Shadow Weaver said a lot of stuff and not much of it was real. Now everyone knows about it.” She nodded, looking to the side thoughtfully.

„Sometimes it is true, but not in this case.” Dr. Moors said, the cylinder resting among the other packages on the vehicle. He was extremely tied, though from what he said it was rather doubtful that anything would happen to him, even if he fell out of a speeding vehicle. He was in outer space...

„What do you mean?” Comrade General asked anxiously.

The Doctor extended one of the metal tentacles and rubbed his lid with a grotesquely human gesture.

„I heard that these types of creatures have been living in space for eons and have been encountered by Mi-Go many times, standing in the way of their great and far-reaching plans. Well, our lord’s right hand didn't lie as much as you might think, although as far as I know it didn't realize how terrifyingly beautiful our universe is.

Lonnie looked at the brain in the top hat silently before commenting.

"It's not knowledge that will make me sleep better."

„But every knowledge makes our lives richer and fuller. We just have to learn to enjoy it as the most wonderful delicacy.”

"I'm sorry to butt in, Comrade General, but there is wisdom in the doctor's words." Scarlett interjected. These types of creatures can become useful to us if we learn to control them.”

Lonie was silent, her lips pressed together. She looked down. She seemed depressed since that meeting on Dead Mountain. Something was bothering her, but they didn't know what. She continued to sleep with them, but in all other respects she had distanced herself from them.

„Do you really see me like that? As a general capable of doing anything in the name of victory?” she asked quietly, though he wasn't entirely sure who.

„That's what leadership is all about. Making decisions no one else could.” Scarlet said

The former cadet giggled with an absolutely joyless laugh.

"Glimmer already did it once… Is it better then?" she asked herself, and looked at them in surprise, as if she had only just noticed that they were still here.

„When you're packed, let's go. Kyle with Rogelio and me with Scarlet...and the doctor.

Normally, he wouldn't have cared which one he was riding with because he loved them both equally, but now he felt that Lonnie needed the closeness of one of them more than ever before...

She did not return from Mystacor as soon as she wished. The events that took place there deserved meticulous research in order to explain, although she wasn't sure if she wanted to know truth. “I was fighting the non-dead. A being that has risen from the dead…” she thought as she walked through Brightmoon's

bright and clean corridors. If anyone had told her that a corpse had risen and drank the blood of living beings, she would have burst out laughing in their face. An autopsy performed by a medic from the Fright Zone revealed that the entity she "killed" had been dead for some time, though it's hard to say since when… Only Aize was not shocked. Frightened yes, but not shocked…They also said that this statue represented Netis, the lady of magic and mystery. She snarled because she had had enough of this Eridani nonsense, and she didn't like that it could take root on Etheri, her planet. She walked along wagging her tail slightly, full of anxiety, wanting to talk to Glimmer and ask her for help. Melog walked beside her, emanating anxiety and nervousness.

„It's you!” she heard a voice coming from the side corridor. The sound of it sounded eerily familiar to her. She turned around and saw a tall woman. Pointed ears indicated that she was a Seihe, but she had gray skin and dark blue hair. She was dressed in dark blue robes and wore a veil over her face. She looked so familiar that she felt the hairs on the back of her neck stand on end.

„Yes?” she asked in such an uncertain voice that she hadn't heard from herself in over five years, almost six. - How can I help you?" *No, it can't be*

„You're the Light Spinner ward?” the woman asked, and she felt a warm tingle of relief run through her body. "No, it's not her. Shadow Weaver is as dead as she was." She smiled at her interlocutor without hiding her claws.

"You mean Shadow Weaver, no one has called her in diffrent way in thirty years. And no one doubted that this name perfectly reflected her nature. But you're right, I'm Grand Marshal Catra and she raised me, if conditoning can be called upbringing.” she replied in a firm voice. She wasn't afraid of this woman... She Shadow Weaver wasn't afraid either, not anymore... but if she came back as non-dead...

„My sister always liked old fairy tales.”

„Are you her sister? She had a sister? she gasped with difficulty. The idea of having a sibling was almost unknown to the cadets, but in the case of Hordak's right hand… She was a mystical figure to them, divine as they would say on Eridani. She could kill almost anyone in the Fright Zone, though she sometimes had to resort to trickery, and it was up to her good will to torture someone as a matter of discipline. Having a sister, family… anyone close to her? It wasn't on her mind.

„She didn't mention us? It's so typical of her. She betrayed her family by going to Mystacor instead of serving her clan.” said the woman. Hearing her words made her blink in disbelief.

„Excuse me? You accuse her of living in Mystacor? Of all the evil, horrible, or just simply mean she had done, it bothers you that she moved to a sorcerer's college... A woman who was fond of child abuse..." She spoke with growing agitation, but the strange one cut her off.

"And exalted dramas ... what she instiled in you. As I heard about her second ward, she also likes to show off senselessly."

Now, hearing the woman's words, perhaps for the first time in many years, she was speechless. *Does she know what she's talking about? Did she sleep the last thirty years under a rock? Seihe were long-lived, but not so detached from reality…* she thought looking at her interlocutor. After a minute, she decided she hated it. It was a record, even Horde Prime took longer.

"Tell me who you are and what you want from me, instead of wasting my time talking about things you have no idea about…" she snapped, and Melog radiated the red of their anger. The strange woman looked at her with piercing green eyes. For a moment, a stupid question flashed through her mind, whether Shadow Weaver ... Light Spinner looked at her interlocutors that way too.

„I am Midnight Mask, Black Blade of the Royal Yago Clan. I have come here to negotiate the resumption of trade relations... after

the appropriate compensation has been paid.” said Midnight Mask in the hard, stern tone she had grown accustomed to throughout her childhood. She smiled the way she hadn't since the end of the war, menacingly and contemptuously.

"Queen Glimmer will talk to you when she sees fit, and she has more important things to do. Herr own wedding, Victory Day celebrations, negotiations to form a galactic alliance, or even deciding what to eat for tea, so please get out of my way and mind your own business. She took a step forward, waiting for Midnight Mask to move away. The woman narrowed her eyes to very narrow ;slits.

"There will be consequences for your impertinence!” She huffed, but only chuckled in response.

"Are you threatening me, Great Marshal of Etheria, someone who wasn't afraid of your sister, of whom you're a pathetic imitation, or even Horde Prime? Or maybe you are threatening Queen Glimmer? Techmaster Bow? She-Ra herself? Or maybe the whole alliance at once, because why split up? Do you really understand how idiotic you sound?”

Midnight Mask snorted contemptuously and turned away, then walked her way. She frowned as she watched him leave. “I'll have to have someone follow her... Or she'll cause trouble. Good thing Adora isn't here. Her relationship with Shadow Weaver was more complicated... and it would be harder for her to turn the bitch off... or would it be better if the three of them talked about her cute little sister?" she thought, and headed for the Queen's office.

The door was guarded by Brother Blade, the only clone in the Brightmoon Guard, at least for now. He was accepted mainly because of the symbolic meaning of the act, one of the former invaders was now defending their queen, but it must be admitted that he performed his duties admirably. Surpassing the skills of Brightmoon's former guardians may not have been much of a feat, but Brother Blade was vigilant, disciplined, and valiant. And

also quite likable. He had long, shoulder-length hair, and his eyes were a deep green.

"I would like to kindly inform Grand Marshal Catra that Queen Etheria Glimmer is asleep, and judging by the volume of her snoring, quite well." he said as soon as he saw her

Indeed, she heard loud snoring coming from inside. In recent months, Glimmer had begun to resemble Adora in her penchant for throwing herself into work. In fact, it should be starting to worry her, but after the wedding, all four of them will go on what is called a honeymoon. Quite a nice custom of lying in bed together and doing nothing. Most importantly, it had absolutely nothing to do with honey, which she hated.

„Sorry, but I need to take her time. But then I'll tell her to go to sleep.” she said with a friendly smile. Blade's brother opened the door for her, and she entered the office. Once she had it, she realized she missed Wrong Hordak. "I wonder where he is now? Let nothing happen to him because of Entrapta's strange and sily idea, she thought, worrying for a moment about the fate of her extraordinary friend.

Glimmer was sleeping, leaning on the table, her head lyinh on her arms. Her wings fell over her shoulders. She grew them after the war and at first they were a curiosity that annoyed her more than they pleased her, but the sight of Glimmer trying to fly on tiny wings and getting nervous when she failed was extremely amusing. But now they had grown, and while they were still nowhere near the size of her mother's, they already allowed her to glide. They were also admired in Eridani, where having wings was the domain of their leaders. Papers were scattered around, as well as a small sandwich. She smiled mischievously. Stealing food from others while they slept was one of her favorite pastimes. She approached the queen slowly and carefully reached over to the sofa and took a bite, then grimaced in disgust. “Apple jelly, herring and pate? Did that occur to her?" she thought, but ate the rest. After all, it was stupid to leave traces of the crime ... It was

probably some family treat, a recipe passed down from generations. She crept up to Glimmer and leaned in slowly.

"Hey Sparkle, you fell asleep at the alliance council meeting..." she said softly into the queen's ear. Glimmer jumped sharply and called out.

„I don’t sleep! I heard everything.” She looked around with blank and frightened eyes. But then she realized where she was and looked at her reproachfully.

„Come on?! You look so funny and cute when you wake up and you don't know where you are or what you've been doing, but you pretend otherwise.”

„Very funny.” she said, frowning. Melog jumped on the table and started rubbing against her as an apology.

„Sorry, sorry.” She laughed, but then became serious. Look, we need to talk about something.”

„Did something happen? Something about Auntie Casta?” Glimmer asked cautiously, she knew that their relationship with Castaspella was not the warmest, although both tried to improve it

„Not exactly ... I went so that they would copy one book ... and everything got a bit complicated ...” she sighed and began to tell her about everything. About her coming to Mystacor, meeting Aize, going through that damn book, going through the scribbles with the scribes, finding the corpse, and finally fighting the non-dead monster… Glimmer listened to her story carefully, occasionally making a quiet comment like "It's weird… ohhh… Incredible!" but after the description of the fight with this creature, she blinked her eyes a few times and asked uncertainly...

„Are you sure he was non-dead? Maybe it just seemed like it?”

she sighed. She was ready for these kinds of questions. In the old days, she would have snapped at anyone who didn't believe her,

but now she answered her friend in a calm voice.

"I'm sure, he didn't die until I pierced his chest. Besides, he had been there for ages, alone and locked up. Castaspella and that weird Nightgale can tell you I'm telling the truth." she said firmly. Though the Head Sorceress of Mystacor had been in a trance while they fought the creature, that didn't change much. Glimmer groaned and collapsed on the table.

„I believe you, but understand ... The dead do not walk and do not bite the living, it's like a definition."

„It will have to change the definition ..." she said more gently, and the queen rubbed her forehead

„Still, then ... Why do I have the impression that problems multiply? I thought life would be easier after all this, but I feel like it's getting harder."

She smiled at the queen because she felt exactly the same.

„Maybe it's just us, Sparkle, because the last few years weren't so bad. Only now we have more activities and this wedding… Anything else happened?"

„An emissary from the Isles of Sorrow wanders the corridors, and she took to heart making my life ... full of sorrow. She keep asking when we will make amends for the past insults we have inflicted on them, though I am not sure what amends and what insults it might be."

She winced.

„We already met in the corridor and had a ... chat. You know that's Shadow Weaver's sister?"

Glimmer's astonished look showed that she had no idea.

„Her sister... She had a family?"

She nodded.

„I couldn't believe it either. It seemed so ridiculously absurd...”

Glimmer thought for a moment.

„You know, everyone ... almost everyone had a family. And almost everyone was once a child. Even she wasn't always… what she had become.” There was a note of regret in the queen's voice.

She looked at her friend. Of all the inhabitants of Etheria, only Glimmer knew the better, nobler side of the Shadow Weaver. She taught her sorcery and gave her much of what she knew. That's what made her such a good queen. Even after learning that a dark sorceress had sent her father to Beast Island, she couldn't hate her. I guess only Castaspella had slightly warmer feelings for her. Finally, Glimmer spoke up.

„And what she said. this sister.” – Glimmer asked

"She said her name was Midnight Mask and claimed to be some kind of Black Blade. And then she started threatening me with repercussions for my impertinence.”

The queen ground in her mouth a bunch of extremely nasty, but also picturesque swear words. She could never get over how a princess and queen could use such language. "Where did she learn it? What did Angela tell her when she heard those words?” Hordak hated swearing as much as alcohol, and had him banished from the Fright Zone. Shadow Weaver punished them severely for "foul tongue," and even now she had a hard time coming up with a harsher word than "Damn."

„Consequences! She threatened you in my palace!? cried the queen at last.

„Yeah, I guess it's family custom. I explained to her who she was threatening and told her she was just a poor imitation of her sister. She left offended, but I'll have the guards keep an eye on her. It may not be Shadow Weaver, but someone calling

themselves a black blade must be dangerous.” She sighed and added „I have one request to you, Sparkle”

Glimmer raised an eyebrow curiously.

„You could teleport Castaspella and Bow's dads to Mikah. They want to discuss with him the matter of this book and what happened in the underground of Mystacor. They don't want another Shadow Weaver to be born. :Or come back from the dead: she added in mind.

Glimmer nodded but then said.

„Netosa asked you and Entrapta to visit her. He has something important to show you. I'd take you right away, but my teleport still doesn't work on the island. Hordak must be happy about it, but it makes communication very difficult.

She sighed heavily.

„I'll pick up Entrapta first. I really wanted to visit her, and Netosa better not meet Hordak. Our animosity isn't that long and deep... If things get out of hand, I'm not sure I can separate them... And to tell you the truth, I don't know if I want to.”

Night Gale liked Scarlet's body, but at the same time she felt as if she had been tied up with metal wire. All the time she had the feeling that the wire would break and return to its natural form. After taking the form of her dead friend for a long time, she felt the pain, slight at first, but slowly increasing until it finally was becoming unbearable. Fortunately, Castle Crypto was a real labyrinth that few people wandered, and she knew nooks and crannies that no one ever looked into. No one was looking for her. Even the real Scarlet wasn't very popular amongthe cadets, and her disposition don’t won her friends. She was lonely, but she always had been, or at least she had always had time to return to her hated but comfortable true self.

But Lonnie wanted, as always, to be on this trip in person, and of course she wanted her to go with them too. She considered getting out of Night Gale's duties in Mystacor, but that would be suspicious, and besides, the cult would definitely want to keep an eye on the Comrade General doings, especially during this trip for Mi-Go. She could only hope the whole thing didn't take too long or she might have a problem. She absolutely couldn't allow anyone to know the truth about the dark forces permeating Etherian society, but she couldn't afford to lose Lonnie either, because it would mean the loss of years of hard work. From what she had heard from the cult leader, the Voice from Shadow, that to Etheria was coming someone who, by the will of Creeping Chaos, would lead the cult to a bright future, someone very important to her…

It was cold here in the North Reach, though they were at its southern end, relatively friendly, but also inhabited, if fortunately sparsely. Their vehicles were gravity powered, the same way as the Horde used in their tanks, though slightly more efficient due to Entrapta's improvements, and unlike many other vehicles in Hordak's army, they where quite comfortable. It was also the result of the ingenuity of the purple-haired princess. She wrapped her arms around Lonnie's waist, as did Kyle with, but he had trouble getting around the mighty lizard torso. Lonnie had a strong, lithe body and was quite attractive. She considered taking advantage of the fact that her relationship with her boyfriends had cooled, but that could be risky for a number of reasons. First of all, it could weaken the People's Rebellion, and it was needed by Creeping Chaos as a pawn on the board that was Etheria.

Eventually they came to a small lake that froze over at dusk. They decided to stay here, eat, settle their needs and discuss further plans. Some azure Etherian bird splashed in its waters. It was quiet and peaceful, Kyle seemed quite content despite the cold. Imp slept snuggled up in Rogelio's back carrier, which he only left here... well, when he had to. Lonie unfolded the map and turned on the old navigation datapad.

„According to old Grizzol maps, as well as satellite maps downloaded from the Prime’s installation, we are on the right

track. It's some hour's drive from here. Parts of that relay Catra had installed would be perfect for our plans, it's a weird the original was never used. „Lonnie said with a much better mood.

„It wouldn't be of much use. No matter how much Hordak amplified the signal, it still wouldn't penetrate into another realm of existence.” Night Gale said. They looked at her questioningly.

„Etheria was hidden in another plane called Despondos. It was an artificially constructed place, a little universe, created by the First Ones to hide their weapons.”

„Grizzol who will be happy that he was freezing his ass here for no reason. Well, this time it will worked.” Lonnie grunted

"Prime was able to subspatially transmit information in his empire, it may not have covered a large area, at least compared to his fantasies ... We have one, but the Mi-Gos use much more standard technology in this area, even if using the biological equivalents of our devices . Of course, they also often use magic and technomagic.” Dr. Moors was saying, gesticulating with his tentacles

"Can't they use magic to talk to their own now?" Kyle interjected, and Lonnie raised an eyebrow questioningly.

“As far as I know, the Overseer has no magic skils, at least not powerful enough.” replied the brain in the cylinder.

"If they had someone powerful enough in that aspect, they would have made contact with their people many years ago…" Scarlet added.

„But a moment ago you said that once ... when we were in another dimension and then such contact was impossible.”

She refrained from showing irritation. *Is this how you felt listening to the ignorant? Like Father, for example?* She smiled the gentle, inscrutable smile she reserved for Scarlet and began to explain.

“Other planes can be contacted, from Despondos but not the first material plane we're in now, though it still wasn't easy. I guess that's a loophole the First Ones overlooked, because they couldn't use magic well, not like us. It is said that in Umbracore, a lost school of magic, other realms, such as the Abyss and Abadon, were often reached to summon terrible beasts to do their bidding. Let's not forget about our former lead officer, of course. The being she summoned was said to be even more powerful than She-Ra..”. she said and almost swore, realizing she might have said too much.

Lonnie scowled at her as if Scarlet had told her she was about to cut off her leg.

„I'll sleep much better knowing this. You can be pleased with yourself!”

They arrived as was said, an hour later. The land was covered with dwarf trees, which covered many small and unusually symmetrical hills. Kyle looked around, really got the bonfire idea into his head.

„This is the Land of Barrows.” she said over the communicator.

„Bar… what?” Kyle asked.

„These are tombs. Apparently, in the old days, the local inhabitants buried their rulers here. We travel around the cemetery.”

The dream of a bonfire went out like a match flame in the rain.

Unfortunately, the building erected here by the Horde has been completely destroyed. Lonnie began to show off her newfound swearing skills, but something else caught her interest. On the highest mound stood an obelisk of black metal, covered with blue inscriptions in Aklo. At the top was an effigy of the head of a red-eyed monster with monstrous fangs. Kyle stood next to her.

„This head is even similar to Hordak, but such inscriptions remind me on this stele in the mountains, or is it also something related to this Atakaka?” He asked. She didn't even have the strength to get angry, she was so fascinated by what she saw.

“Atlah-Naha…no, that's something else entirely. Lonnie calmed down a bit and stood next to her. “This one is dedicated to Ithaqua, the walker of the wastes, the silent wind, the great cannibal. „she said with undisguised delight. Lonnie growled furiously.

"It's wonderful that you found some fucked-up horror to be fascinated by, but tell me what the fuck I care."

She smiled triumphantly.

„Ithaqua is one of the Great Old Ones, a very powerful being... It's the second such monument on our planet. Does this mean that there are more of them dedicated to other Great Old Ones? It's... puzzling and a little disturbing... at least for those who don't have an open mind...” seeing as Comrade General narrowed his eyes at her, she went straight to the point. “Somewhere nearby was the city of the Elder Things, a powerful and ancient race that had roamed the universe for a billion years.

„Are these relatives of Mi-Go? Kyle asked, paling visibly.

„Not exactly... Their technology was more focused on using purely biological beings, though they were extremely skilled physicists, although they used machines on a much smaller scale even than our allies, let alone the First Ones. Sometimes they fought with Mi-Go, sometimes they cooperated... They were ruined by the rebellion of their slave race called the Shogoths...”

„Slaves?” Kyle asked hesitantly, and Rogelio joined in with a grunt.

„Conscious beings that are the exclusive property of other intelligent beings. A bit like servants of our old friend Horde Prime, although usually with a buy and sell option.” she explained with a gentle smile. Her companions looked at her with horror at the

memory of a practice not practiced on Etheri aalmost since the departure of the First Ones. But Lonnie thought about something.

„They fought with Mi-Go... You think there might still be something in their city. she asked, and Scarlet nodded.

„The technology of the Ancient Races could have lasted for millions of years. – „Just like the traps and guards they left behind" she added mentally.

Lonnie looked at the ruins of the outpost that Grizzol had built. The commander probably built the outpost in this place, because the obelisk located next to it was visible from afar and was an excellent landmark.

"Okay, now that we're here, let's look for these ruins, otherwise this whole journey will be just one big waste of time..."

„You are right, Comrade General. The light is darkening, night is coming. It would be unwise to be in such a place after dark." said Night Gale thoughtfully. The two men nodded in support, and Lonnie agreed, obviously not wanting to waste any more time. However, the sorcereress sensed the dark force churning under their feet. The destruction of the Heart of Etheri and the release of magic had unexpected results. As the light of the mystical moons waned, something awakened in the dark corners of Etheria.

He smiled as he saw the flickering flames of the fire that had just been lit. He could have used magic, but all those years on Beast Island he had tried to not waste his power and he hadn't changed that habit. He looked around the old mountain hut where he had stayed when he left Brightmoon. It had been happening to him lately, and more often, and he had considered moving here permanently. Nothing kept him in the palace. His daughter was a strong and independent woman who did not need her old father to interfere in her affairs. Especially now that he's starting his own

family. She was also a queen, and better than Etheria could have hoped for. She made mistakes, like any ruler, but she was able to learn from her failures. If she needs his help or company, she can always visit him. Although much could not help her. At most, show how to catch the tastiest worms. When Adora found him, the war had just ended. He helped lead the Rebelion until… He was a man of war, and who needs one in peacetime?

But there were other things as well. He was… Dead, dead for thirteen years… For thirteen years, everyone in Brightmoon mourned him, he was to them a symbol of the invader's wickedness. He felt… like he had let everyone down. That he had failed everyone with his life. Especially since they had not long ago lost the queen who had ruled them for centuries... and in return they received an old man who had lost his life.

Angie... That was another reason he didn't want to be in the castle... His love for his wife and daughter had sustained him through all those years of torment on Beast Island. And then it turned out that she had left, had sacrificed herself to save them all. Now, every nook and cranny of the palace reminded him of her, the happy years they had spent together... The few moments of peace they had spent... remained only a painful memory that only hurt him. He couldn't stand this feeling of loss, so he spent more and more time here. He felt much more at home in this midwife's hut in the wilderness than in the chambers of the palace. He was used to enduring hardship, though of course this place was no match for the Beast Island in the hardships it exposed those who lived here.

He sensed a burst of magic. He could recognize the vibrations caused by Glimmer's teleportations, and even determine if she had arrived alone or with friends. This time she had brought at least two people with her, so either Glimmer's friends wanted to visit him or something very important had happened. Given that Adora was now on Icarus, it was probably the latter. He sighed, picked up his sorcerer's staff, then stood up. He felt pain in his old bones and stepped outside. In front of the cabin he saw his sister and also Bow's dads. Everyone looked around the forest around

them. Castaspela a little apprehensively, Lance and George curiously. Well, his sister and wild nature weren't a very good combination, but Bow's fathers, for all their eccentricity, lived in a library nestled in the middle of a Whispering Wood. They had to be able to cope with a variety of conditions.

„Oh, welcome to my modest ... a bit rough doorstep. I can make mulled wine with cinnamon, I also have stew and cheese, if you wantk we can make fondue.” he said, although he rather expected that it wouldn't end with a dinner with friends. The eyes of all three lit up at his proposal, but Castaspella shook her head first and, smiling sadly, said.

„I'd love to, but maybe later. We have important matters to discuss.”

Hearing it in her voice, he understood that the matter was extremely serious. He invited everyone inside and began preparing the mulled wine as he listened to Castaspelia's account. His sister told him about Catra's arrival with the Thousand Thousand Masks, finding the corpse, how she had gone into a trance. About the vision of an alternative reality, although she got a little confused here. Finally, she told about the Great Marshal's fight with the non-dead monster. He listened to all this with full seriousness, with absolute concentration. Then he poured everyone a mug of mulled wine with cinnamon.

„The light is darkening, night is coming. We need to warm up.” he said, breaking the silence.

„She liked it.” Castaspella suddenly blurted out. – „Fruit wine from Plumeria.”

„Angela? I mean Queen Angela?? Lance said surprised. He and his husband, they never met his wife.

„No... Shadow Weaver. Glimmer always made sure she had a bottle in her chamber. Apparently… the day we won, she drank the last we had. Sorry, I don't know why I'm talking about this.”

She looked embarrassed at her brother. She thought she had hurt him by mentioning the dark sorcerer. He had no problem with that, he and Catra had talked about that woman, but his sister was unaware of it, hardly knowing who he had become.

"Catra told me that at the end of her career in the Fright Zone, Shadow Weaver often got drunk on the nasty moonshine they made there…" he said and smiled sadly. “At least she drank something nobler in Brightmoon.” They were silent for a moment, listening to the sound of flickering flames.

-„Our world is changing. The destruction of the Heart of Etheri unleashed the magic that is now free. Former powers hidden in the farthest corners of our planet have awakened. We have forgotten them in the dark years of war.” he said with grim solemnity. “We have to act now to prevent the situation from spiraling out of control again. Lance and George, go to Frosta, the Kngdom of Snow. If the reports sent to Glimmer were true, the earthquakes caused by the planet's imbalance uncovered an ancient city... You have a copy of „Horison's Etheri Description”, check it's not the same city... Castaspella, be on your guard. Mystacor has always been a hotbed of dark mysteries. There, the Shadow Weaver gained her dark powers, who knows what terrible secrets may be hiding in your college. Some worship terrible and ancient dark beings willing to offer power... at a terrible cost...”

„What will you do? his sister asked him.

„I will continue to explore the Valley of Shattered Armor... I chose this hut because it is nearby. Some people say that there are suspicious things going on here, I've seen a few myself. The ruins of Umbracor are also nearby. After the Wedding, I'll ask Adora to visit it together. And we'll take Scorpia too, her family had a secret here, she has a right to know it. Family secrets are often the darkest

The light was darkening Night was coming. She gave all the orders of the guards, because she was going to disappear for a few days. She had one more thing to do before she left. She and Melog went to her and Adora's common room. As she opened the door, she smelled her lover, her fiancée… her neary-wife. She felt a stab of unspeakable longing. The Melog glowed yellow-green. It was a mess, well Adora was always the tidier one, and then she headed over to the cupboard where they kept their keepsakes. She looked at the shelf where the two oldest ones were. One was the the blanket wrapped around the child found by Hordak, and the other was the cardboard box in which she had been found. Shadow Weaver kept the blanket in her workshop and studied it for years, but she slept in a cardboard box for the first months of her life because she couldn't sleep anywhere else, but then their „caretaker” decided to throw him out, so she and Adora hid it. They've moved him here and there over the years to keep him safe. When she caught a cold after traveling to the North Reach, she confided his existence to Scorpi, when she delirious during the fever. Somehow, he survived the entire war and occupation, and when the Scorpion princess found him, she decided to give him to her friend. She was happy with this gift, because she was irrationally attached to this stupid box ... She smiled, when she touched the corner of the cardboard with the back of her hand, she felt the memories flowing to her. Adora didn't want to give her blanket to Entrapta to examine it, she didn't want to know the secret of her origin, because the truth could break her again ... She didn't push her because she always loved her for who she was, where she was from did not matter. In her case... She told herself it didn't matter to, that maybe she wasn't born on Etheria either... That she was a stranger here too... But damn it did. None of the officials in the Fright Zone cared. No one was interested in where this cat girl came from... In fact, if it wasn't for Adora, no one would have been interested in her, she would have been sitting in this cardboard box for who knows how long, maybe no one would ever find her... Shadow Weaver would probably be spitting in her chin now, if she found out what secret the ward she disliked was hiding. But her contempt was so poignantly deep that it never even crossed her mind that she might be hiding

something more than a crying, frightened child. "But she had time to see how wrong she was, though she couldn't admit it until the very end," she smiled with grim satisfaction. She will now take the packaging to Entrapta for examination. Maybe he'll find anything. And then something touched her. She took the cardboard in her hands and looked at it. She hadn't done that in years, since the last time she hid him. It was a carton of applesauce, which is probably why she always dreamed about this delicacy as a child... Because it reminded her of the place where she had been found. Only now did she see that there was an image of a smiling apple on one of the walls... No one in the Horde would bother to decorate the packaging, and certainly not with such cute drawings. The writing was in a common language, widely used in the galaxy, though many planets had their own, but she didn't recognize the font, though she'd read thousands of pages of documents when she was Hordak's right-hand man... She was too fancy by Fright Zone standards. And then she saw the writing. "Sweet Fruit tm" and below "Made 100% from Kesler apple trees" and below "Feel the taste of nature's gifts."

She started laughing, tears streaming down her cheeks. The proof was always in front of her eyes.

Fears, worries and sorrows.

Itel watched as Eti sat down on the bed and put on a leather glove. She always started with that after everything... even though it was only their third time... She didn't know if... if they were closer, she would do it too... Did it have any special meaning for the feline girl? Did she show that she didn't care? That it meant nothing to her. Was it really just a moment of… fun for her? Consolation? She felt stab of pain in the heart…

When Eti put on pants and panties, it always required some effort from her because of the tail, she touched the tips of her fingers the short soft hair that grew on the feline girl's back. Eti stiffened for a moment, but then relaxed. Once upon an unexpected touch, she would have flinched at best, perhaps even recoiled. It was some progress.

„You know, it's not your fault we're traveling here. We all decided it together.” her friend said.

„But if it wasn't for me, you wouldn't vote for that?” she asked in a sad voice. Eti turned to her and said.

„What difference does it make... We'd have to fly somewhere anyway. I will go anyway where you are, and for me all places in the galaxy are similar.”

Her friend was usually sincere, even if she was insensitive. She was never nice to please anyone either. Sometimes she twisted the truth, sometimes she told tales, but she rarely lied. Not calcultedly…

„It's not an answer”. she replied to her friend. Eti sighed.

"You're… my friend, just my best friend. You all are friends and I want us all to be together.

"A friend... so that was..." Itel said bitterly.

Eti lowered her head...

„You were sad and I wanted to comfort you. You know damn well I'm no good at this, so I thought you'd enjoy it.”

The Solarian laughed helplessly. Indeed it was. Eti found it over a cup of half-melted sweet cream ice cream, staring straight ahead, choked with fear and guilt. It was then, after seeing that message, that she realized what a terrible place they were flying. She survived the Swarm Attack and believed that she couldn't find anything worse, and here ... She took her friends, the only family she had and threw them to be devoured by evil much worse than the mindless mass of claws and maws. She didn't think about all the stories about the White Demons, she believed that the truth would come out as soon as they got there. And it come out. Evil who was destroying the planets. This Horde Prime chose to do to others what had been done to her loved ones. Why? It's… Unbelievable. Even if he is dead, if he had been defeated, what did it matter? She exposed her friends to witness such a terrible tragedy. She made them relive the nightmare of Kesler's fall. She knew it would leave scars on their souls. Even on Eti's soul, though the girl didn't show it like the others.

When Eti saw that Itel would not eat her ice cream, she asked if she could finish it for her. The feline girl didn't really like ice cream and most sweets, but she liked sweet cream ice cream. Without a word, he handed her the bucket. Only after devouring half of it did Eti ask if she was okay, and then the elf burst into tears. After a while, Eti hugged her, she wasn't as clumsy as she used to be. And then they ended up in Itel's room and… For a moment she felt fine, but she knew it wasn't true, that they would always be just friends.

„You know what? I don't think we have anything to worry about!” Eti said, and Itel pricked up her pointed elven ears.

"Because, you know, I guess we should start with the fact that this is a whole country of Wormdaks, cloned in honor of Archwormdak. You can't expect too much from them."

She sighed and shook her head.

„Wrongdak can fight, believe me. He's nice, but he can be dangerous, he just doesn't feel like it. But his mean brothers might be waiting for us there." Itel said in a resigned tone. Eti shrugged.

„But we didn't come here to fight anyone. We just have to go to this Etheria and find a whatsit for this captain and we're back. We just have to keep our heads down." she said getting out of bed. She went to the mirror and wiped her face.

„And that Etheria? If the Lady of Chaos really lives there? And the rest of these monsters." the solarian asked looking at her friend. *She's So Beautiful*

"It's just the talk of this drow. drow! Who could believe someone like that? That's dumber than believing the Lord Admiral. And besides, you know, with our disposition, we can be friends with such a lady of Chaos. I think it's time to change the hair color ..." she said. Then there was a knock on the door. Itel felt herself turn red. She didn't want anyone to catch them here. She wanted to scream not to come in when Eti opened the door with her tail.

Toshi flew inside, who immediately started rubbing against Eti, and a smiling Rosie stood in the doorway.

„I'm only here to let It in..." said the girl in sign language, when suddenly she saw Eti naked from the waist up, and then itel on the bed, trying to cover herself with a blanket. The white-haired girl turned beet red, just like the Elf. She covered her eyes and tried to speak, but doing both were impossible for her. She finally slammed the door and ran down the hall.

"I must have done something not good." Eti said in her usual monotonous voice

Bina got up, sat on the edge of the bed and wiped her forehead.

„Fuck, we did it, didn't we?” Bina said. Her cabin was no better than the others. Well, she was a captain in name only.

Dilayla, who was lying next to her, also sat down next to her.

„We slept in the same bed naked, I guess that says it all.” The mercenary bared white tiny teeth inherited from her elven ancestors.

„I didn't need to drink so much.” said the red-haired woman.

„And you played cards too. Needless to say you won?” Dilayla smiled wider and wider.

The captain snorted.

„Because I cheated, I'm too good at it.” she started getting dressed.

„Not that I'm complaining, sometimes the deceived really wants to be deceived.” The mercenary also started putting on clothes. She did it efficiently, like a soldier.

„I don't usually do this with passengers. In fact, I expected sooner to end up in bed with Arkan-tar. He seems to be the type who does not refuse and quickly forgets.” Bina grunted.

„He looked poisoned after seeing this news, I think he realized where he arived.” replied Dilayla. Bina looked askance at her.

„You don't seem to care much”.

The half-elf shrugged.

„ I'm a mercenary, I've seen a lot of terrible things in my life. No shadow beasts will scare me. . she said, and when Bina narrowed her eyes suspiciously, she added. „And i got used to crap pushed

by politicians. The enemy is always mindless monsters. You don't look scared either.”

Good point

„I guess I see propaganda bullshit in this, too. I've seen much bigger shit being foisted on the masses, like making a hero out of a one Lord Admiral. You don't know him, do you?" She added seeing Dilayla frown. "Anyway, I have to go now." I have a talk with Lady Cala soon, because Verthani and Lashunti want to see what Lady Cala is transporting.” She smiled as she saw Dilayla wince. "I know you and Eti hate her, and I don't like her either... But if she wants to show me something..."

„Sure.” Dilayla said. She finished dressing and stood up. "Only when your face melts, Don’t hold a grudge against anyone." I'll go over the equipment, then try to get Rosie to train. The girl has talent. It's a pity to let it go to waste.

Arkan-tar was worried. He was worried as hell. This travel was turning into something he was absolutely unprepared for despite years of putting himself in danger. He had heard of what a scary place the Ravaged Zone was, but seeing was believing… He had seen the remnants of extinct civilizations. Well, researching them was his job. Cultures have been born and died, whether through conquest, natural disasters, or simply morphing into something new. It was the natural order of things, it was easy to distance yourself from such matters when you study civilizations that had been dead for thousands of years. But when you've seen the extermination on a planetary scale, and you hear the words of the one who did the carnage... then you realize the tangibility of evil. "By all the gods and devils, I see his face every day!" he thought as he looked at Wrongdak, who still hadn't recovered from the shock of picking up the signal from that Horde Ultimate. The existence of such a person did not surprise him. Whenever a ruler died without heir, his empire was torn apart by his sucesors until the strongest emerged or it crumbled. He was much more worried

about this Lady of Chaos and the other beings that appeared there. The Lady of Thorns in particular, for she fitted in very well with his knowledge of the dark Fae, who often combined life and death, pain and pleasure, destruktion and rebirth. As a Verthani, even if not native-born, he had an instinctive aversion to absolutes. Of course, maybe everything was lies and propaganda... But often evil can only be destroyed by greater evil, and how monstrous must have been the force that annihilated someone who was murdering entire populations of planets.?

The next morning, Lady Cala was to show them an object she was carrying. Bina and Rechiza were also present, and of course Lady Cala, though without Miss Daisy. The Dark Sorceress had been spending more and more time with this strange elven mistic lately, and judging by the scent she often exuded, they were rather relishing liquors of very dubious quality. Lady Cala stood by a chest made of a strange green stone. The noblewoman knelt and lifted the lid. Inside was an unusual red stone interspersed with green metal veins. It was the size of a human head. It seemed almost identical, though much larger, like the stone set in Lady Cala's ring.

„We call it Bloodstone. It has been in my family for hundreds or even thousands of years, ever since the daughter of Mary, the founder of our ruu, came to Carurystal. It remained lost and forgotten for centuries, somewhere in the endless underground stretching under our castle. I found it with the ring when I wanted to know the history of our bloodline. It is said that he comes from Etheria and allowed the use of magic that permeated this world …" said the aristocrat. „I want to return it to the people of that planet as a gift to show the best side of the galaxy and of course the pact worlds." said Lady Cala.

Bina looked at the artifact with a hint of skepticism.

„Doesn't look dangerous, but... was he just a decoration?" she asked, tilting her head.

"I don't know for sure, but it was said to allow the ring's owner to control Etherian's magic in a unique way. Apparently, there were more similar items, and each of them gave the user a different power. That's all I know."

Bina sighed.

„Nice story. Were your ancestors from there? So you can somehow relate to this Lady of Chaos and the whole Worst Things Ever Squad?" she asked with a hint of irritation in her voice.

„Oh, the answer is simple. It's all a lie. Mara was from Etheria and gave her life for it, would she do it for a planet full of monsters?"

„As you said, it was thousands of years ago... The future will show us the truth. Bina said. She touched the communicator and said. "Alatar calls me to the bridge. He has something important to show me. Bina said and left the hold. He was not surprised, for he knew the gem's origins, albeit only in general terms. It appeared to be the work of a long-extinct reptilian race that was said to have used similar items to manipulate the flow of magical energy. This was consistent with what Lady Cala had said, but also how did it relate to Mara being one of the First Ones. When his glasses, which sometimes showed visions of the past, but only the ancient one. But here he couldn't see anything, and that made him very uneasy...

We must make contact with the Lord Admiral, only he can guarantee our safety ... He thought and also started towards the bridge.

Rosie stood in the doorway to the Arcanic lab, rubbing her eyes. It's not that she got sad when she found out that Eti and Itel were together. She just felt… disappointed. She liked Eti. And Eti liked her too. And she guess they'll still like each other... buddy, won't they? They will continue to play and train… although now they are reluctant to do so. And when they get to some planet, they will

assume that they are on some mission. Only now would she have to be more… careful? Give Eti and Itel more space so that... they can be more together. And to be more of a distance to the feline girl, but now at least she knew why Itel was mean to her even though she hadn't done anything to her. Of course, she had no reason to be jealous. They were just friends, after all. Not even friends, just buddies. They'd only known each other for… ten days… maybe two weeks? She wasn't sure, it was hard for her to keep track of time on the spaceship. However, she liked her very much. She was weird, unusual, funny… she was a real magical cat!

But she still felt sad, and she didn't know why. She wiped her eyes and put on her glasses. Then they showed that someone was talking to her. She turned and saw Miss Daisy standing in the shadows. She looked really scary at that moment.

„Is something wrong child?” she asked smiling gently. She walked over to him and gave him a questioning look.

"No, I'm fine… just…" She hesitated.

"Speak, I'll listen to you... I don't have much to do now anyway..." said the grim elf. Rosie smelled alcohol on her.

„Nothing but... Toshi was hanging around the corridor and wanted to go to Itel's room, so I let him in, but I went inside and... There was Eti and they with Itel... together… you understand...”

Miss Daisy sighed sadly.

„Oh, poor child. She reached a hand to her face. The holographic cloaking quivered, and she felt a slight tingle on her cheek, then the touch of the woman's claws.

„You've only known each other for a moment and you've already felt something you can't name... I understand you. she said, then looked up into the air. How strange that it took them almost two decades to figure out what they have in common when others

only need a few days… or a few hours." the dark sorceress said to herself.

„They? Are you talking about any other girls you've looked after like Lady Cala? she asked curiously.

"Looked after… What a wonderful euphemism… And they were definitely not like Lady Cala… Those girls… They were actually my daughters. In some sense…"

Rosie's eyes widened.

„Did you have children? What happened to them?"

Miss Daisy hesitated.

„Yes. But they don't remember me well. To be honest, I rather hope they don't remember me anymore."

Rosie studied the gloomy woman, trying to decipher her words. She felt pity for the dark sorceress. She too had a family that she had lost. She didn't understand how anyone could want to be forgotten. She suddenly felt so sad. She suddenly embraced the older woman and cuddled up to her. The sorceress flinched, but then placed a clawed hand on her head. There was no tingling, so the woman must have turned off the holographic cloaking

„Don't worry. You are so young and strong. You have your whole life ahead of you. Don't let fear, worries and sorrows ruin your life." said the sorceress, and then Rosie burst into tears.

Dilayla was scared. She was a veteran of dozens of clashes and skirmishes. She has come close to death countless times. She'd even survived invasion of that insane Horde Prime motherfucker ... But now she felt a constant cold stab of fear in her heart. She wasn't afraid of Horde Ultimate, he didn't have that crazy, but in a way sincere, megalomany of his Big Brother... He seemed to be just another power-hungry dictator, which the galaxy had known

so many. He just had a rather unusual PR specialist. She was not at all afraid of the Lady of Chaos and her entourage. She'd heard too much propaganda crap in her life not to be amused hearing about the Lady of Thorns or the Shadow Beast, the true identity of which she had some suspicions. She preferred to trust the Wrongdak's judgment. He may have been good-natured and a bit naive, but he wasn't stupid, and it had slipped through their conversations that his friends were good people, even if they had been through hard life. No… Dilayla was afraid of her companions.

After seeing Lady Cala fight, she had no doubt that this woman didn't need protection. In fact, she feared that she would be able to slaughter a whole group of them without much effort. And without remorse. "She didn't hesitate to rip out Rosie's throat in training. If only the girl had been just a little slower…"

It just felt like Rosie should be afraid too. The likeable and friendly intern defeated the deadliest warrior Dilayla had ever seen in a fight. And on top of that, she didn't remember anything about the clash. When she found out what she had done, the white-haired girl was genuinely terrified. She refused to continue training because she was afraid of hurting someone. The mercenary was also full of fears, both for the girl's life and for what might happen if she fell into a combat trance for longer. She had no idea what secret the girl's past was hiding, but there must have been something very dark about her. That's why she wanted to talk Rosie into continuing her training, maybe then she'd get some clues. Perhaps he will ask Eti for help, after all, the feline girl liked ... or even *liked* the intern.

After looking through the equipment, she decided to look for the girl. She couldn't find her. She finally went to the arcane lab. In the doorway, she saw Rosie and a ghostly entity with a hand on the intern's head. Years of war and fighting instinct kicked in, and before she had time to think, her body reacted and she jumped into the fight...

And Rosie grabbed them with a cybernetic hand in the air and effortlessly held them still. The nightmare figure looked at her in

surprise and said in Miss Daisy's voice.

"Apparently Arkan-tar and Rechiza didn't think it important to inform you." She touched the back of her neck to activate the holographic cloaking and became Miss Daisy. The mercenary widened her eyes and stammered.

„What the fuck...”

„That `s nothing. It's just Miss Daisy. She had a terrible accident once and that's why she looks like this now.” explained Rosie, who let go of the mercenary's hand. Her eyes were red as if she had just cried.

'Rechiza and Arkan-tar saw my face, as did Rosie the night before we left Saltmarsh. It's unfortunate that your comrades treated you this way. I hope this misunderstanding will not affect our future relationship. she said in her strong and powerful voice. Rosie smiled at her

„It's really okay, it's just a misunderstanding.”

Dilayla sighed. „The girl must have found a foster mother like that” she thought, and then they were sumoned bridge.

Dilayla looked around. Almost all crew members were there. Itel tried not to look at Rosie as if she was embarrassed, Eti watched her shoes very intensely, and Rosie was very ostentatiously cheerful. The half-elf sighed, she really didn't have the strength for teenage dramas. Luckily, Bina came to terms with what had happened between them.

„Listen, we just got an emergency call. the captain began. It comes from the convent of Saint Serenia. I immediately inform you that I am required by law to help.”

Arkan-tar winced.

„And how old is the call?” he asked skeptically.

„I'm not sure, maybe months. But rather a few years.” Bina replied. Verthani spread his hands helplessly.

"As you can see, our help is rather useless.” he said with all too much feigned sadness.

"He's right, our mission is more important, and there's nothing we can do anyway." Rechiza added.

„Pathetic cowards,” the mercenary thought and said.

„We can't just let this go on the agenda. Stories of shipwrecked people waiting for years for help have been heard many times. Besides... After all we've seen, after all the testimonies of Horde Prime's crimes, we have to do something... For ourselves. Otherwise, we will let evil win again”.

Wrongdak looked at her with admiration, and Eti, Rosie and ... Miss Daisy with respect. Lady Cala stepped into the center of the room and said.

"Dilayla is right. We cannot pass by this cry for help indifferently. Besides, maybe we'll find some clues there that will help us discover the truth about what's going on here.”

Why do I get the feeling this wasn't the best idea? thought the mercenary staring at the smiling face of the aristocrat.

The hardships of peace

She slept soundly until the chancellor started screaming.

„Frosta. Princess Frosta!”

She woke up but still pretended to be asleep. Maybe she'll be able to sleep again. These meetings were so boring… If Glimmer could fall asleep, why not her. The Queen was not reminded of this, and neither should she! She heard the chancellor sigh heavily.

„The Dread Ice Bane!” she said and immediately lifted her head. She was sitting in her office, in a fur-padded chair. Much more comfortable than the blue crystal throne she had sat on during her official appearances. She had her head resting on one of those thick, dull chronicles that made the perfect pillow.

„Yes. What do i have to do?” she said, trying to keep from rubbing her eyes... She was so bored.

"First of all, I would like to point out that you are commonly known as Princess Frosta, and the name 'Dread Ice Bane' is not befitting one in your position." said the chancellor. He was a tall and bony man with a long, stiff blue beard. He was appointed to the position by her grandmother. He smiled then. For the first and last time

„Why? This Horde Ultimate calls me that... It's a very cool name!” she exclaimed angrily

„This is the name given by the enemy! I shouldn't be using it. The chancellor was indignant… and it made him look quite funny.

„They gave it to me because they respect me! Though maybe not. Then they would have added Lady Ice Bane! Why don't they appreciate me? Don't they find me scary enough?” she asked suddenly sad.

"More like..." He looked at her and hesitated. "It's probably because of your young age." said the chancellor cautiously.

"Glimmer was my age when she fought in the Rebellion... and then she became queen." She looked at the old adviser from under furrowed brows. She became ruler as an eight-year-old child. She was told to be tough as granite rock and stronger than bear. They wanted her to be like a living ice figure. But there was always a fire in her heart. She liked joy and laughter. She liked to throw herself into a fight. But in the realm of Snow, the queen was required to be as cold as the weather in the farthest northern wastes. She should not say a single word without thinking it over ten times. Her every act and gesture was judged, she constantly had to prove that she was worthy of the throne and the runestone.

Only outside the homeland could she truly be herself, and that's where she learned that you can follow your heart. But here she was judged, acknowledged as tainted by the culture of the Warm Lands. Maybe if she'd been born in Brightmoon or Plumeria, but here is the Snow Kingdom... It's the country of the toughest of tough women and men. "Of course, when the Galactic Horde arrived, we fell as quickly as the others" „Maybe we'll stay with Ice Bane? My great-grandmother's name was a skull splitter, and I remember my ancestors being someone called Clawdeen. That would fit.

The Chancellor scratched his cheek.

„Some traditions... Some traditions should be forgotten.” The advisor said in a gentle voice and handed over the document.

„What's that?” she asked bored. She would love to go back to sleep.

„Nothing special.” said the chancellor, smiling ingratiatingly. She glared at him so he added. "It's an proposal to granting you the title of empress." He said suddenly sounding terribly pompous. She blinked several times.

"But I'm already a princess." she asked, not understanding. The Chancellor sighed heavily.

“Your ancestors relinquished that title by treaty with Queen Angela. But she…well…gone. Old treaties no longer apply.” he explained to her. Now she felt like she didn't want to know where this was all leading up to.

„Glimmer is now queen. She's Angela's daughter…” she said hesitantly. The chancellor nodded.

„Yes, but the treaty was made directly with Queen Angela, that's what all our legislators say, so it's no longer valid. We didn't want to raise this issue during the war you so... recklessly pushed us into, but now that there is peace, it would be worth considering the future of the kingdom.”

Hearing that she had pushed the kingdom into war, she pursed her lips in anger. Many accused her of that. That she joined a war that wasn't theirs. But it was the Horde who started it, and Horde was evil! Why did no one understand this?!

„We will just sign this treaty again and there will be no problem.” she said, trying to sound as if she was saying the obvious.

The Chancellor made a sour face.

"Many of your subjects would not be happy with this decision…" he began, but she cut him off.

„Who! show them!” She banged her fist on the table. Her advisor was perplexed.

„For example the leaders of the great clans. Many believe that there is no need to stick to the alliance. The war is finally over. Now it's time for each land to go its own way.” he explained to his Lady.

„But Glimmer is my friend! How can I do this to her.” She screamed indignantly, but also a little scared. *Why do they want*

such things from me!

"A true ruler must be guided by the desires of her subjects, not her own feelings. Sometimes he has to let go of his emotions and turn his heart to ice."

„Glimmer, Adora Bow and even Catra saved us! They saved us all!" She got really angry this time. *How can they not see it!*

„I remind you that Glimmer almost destroyed us earlier by activating the Heart of Etheria, and then brought the Galactic Horde on us!" The adviser's voice became much sterner now.

She flushed with anger and briefly considered locking the man in ice, but saw him touching the back of his neck. She remembered that he had been chipped during the occupation, when she was punching clones in the faces and destroying robots. She felt ashamed of her outburst of anger, and of the fact that she had imagined the chancellor's head encased in ice, but she had no intention of relenting. She sighed and pursed her lips.

„No, I won't sign it. That…would destroy everything". She said in a firm voice

"But princess…" the Chancellor began, but she interrupted him abruptly

„Enough! I won't listen to it End of discussion! Soon Victory Day and my friends' wedding! I won't ruin their day!" she cried, clenching her fists.

„Your involvement in the wedding of a foreign queen is also considered controversial in many circles."

Now she really wanted to punch him in the stupid face. Ever since the end of the war, she had felt the urge to hit someone more and more often. She had the impression that despite the peace, she had to fight much more and on much more difficult fronts. She felt so tired and depressed by hardships of peace. Does Glimmer feel this way too?

Then the Ice Sentinel, one of the guards who have been guarding the rulers of her land for years, looked into the office.

"I'm sorry, but the emissaries have arrived… no… Scholars?" From Brightmoon… or maybe from the Whispering Woods. I'm not sure…" he mused, and she gave him the most murderous look she could muster. "I mean, Mr. Lance and Mr. George want to meet your highness."

She smiled broadly. It was the first pleasant news of the day… the first in a month, actually. However, she looked at the chancellor and restrained her emotions and spoke in a serious voice.

„We are honored to have a PRIVATE audience with the parents of Techmaster Bow, the future royal consort." She looked at the chancellor pointedly.

After a while, Bow's Fathers were ushered into the office. The men looked around the room, Lance's eyes lit up at the sight of those horribly boring books. They were sometimes weird. They were dressed in thick furs, even for the weather typical of her country. They were obviously headed up. Everyone always expected that in her country, all you had to do to freeze was step outside the door... Well, the name Snow Kingdom impresses.

„Welcome visitors from distant lands. Please warm yourself by our fire." she said formally. The men looked at each other in surprise. All they knew was cool, feisty Frosta, but she couldn't be cool, feisty Frosta here. The chancellor left the room, and when he was out of earshot, she smiled from ear to ear. She ran onto the table, then jumped to the floor and started hugging them.

„Uncle Lance, Uncle George! she exclaimed happily.

„When we were promoted to uncles." Lance asked

„When we became grandparents, my dear. In the meantime." George replied and they laughed.

„It's great that you're here. Lately everyone is really bothering me… The heads of the Great Clans criticize everything I do. I have to sign documents all the time, and no matter what I do, it's still wrong”. She growled and clenched her fists.

"Uh…" Lance was saying. „We just wanted to find out about the buried city... Which is actually dug up now... But since you're busy.”

„No problem! I just packs up.” She exclaimed, happy to be freed from this torment, if only for a moment.

"But we didn't even tell her that we were going anywhere… In fact, we didn't even decide ourselves that we were going anywhere…" said George.

„I packed spare clothes just in case.” Lance said.

She hated Beast Island. She never explored this place. She always stopped at a small patch of land that had been cleared. But she knew Adora's story when she had come here in search of Entrapta, whom she had condemned to a fate worse than death by sending her here. She tried to call things by their names, including the harm she had done to others. *All our lives we've been taught to fear this place. Anyone who betrayed or failed was sent here without trial, one Shadow Weaver signature…or mine was enough. The entire Fright Zone lived in constant fear of being send here. And I was helping fuel that fear…* she thought grimly. Whenever she traveled near the Horde's former territory, she felt an overwhelming sense of guilt. In Brightmoon, they knew her mostly as the Grand Marshal, She-ra's beloved, or even the one who had rescued their queen from cruel captivity. *They forgot that I made them lose the previous one...* she thought bitterly. "Maybe I'll ask Entrapta again if there's no way to... isn't there a way to reopen..." she sighed. Even in her mind, she had a hard time formulating the thought.

The dock where the skimmer had moored was empty, though many vehicles could stop here. There was also an airfield for spaceships, of course empty. She felt a pang of remorse. Few people visited Entrapta on Beast Island. Not only because of the bad reputation surrounding this place. Everyone knew who the other inhabitant of the island was, and did not want to meet him here. For decades, Hordak has been feared not only by the free kingdoms, but also by the common people of the Fright Zone. *But I was never afraid of him. From the first meeting, I felt who he really was like* She thought as she walked towards the chaotic yet amazing structure that was Castle Mysterio or Fort Junk as she sometimes called it. *I should come here more often. Entrapta is again stuck in a gloomy and inaccessible castle. She's alone again... Almost* she thought and winced. "But it's not just about him. Not only about him" she thought, looking at the technoflora-covered interior of the island. Even here she heard music. It was on the verge of hearing. At the same time, it penetrated every muscle, every bone and nerve of her body. It reached the very core of her being...

And she was beautiful. She knew others could hear the sound, piercing through. Painful and imperious, taking away all the will to fight, the will to live and exist. It was much worse than the monsters that lived here… That's what Adora and Mikah said. But to her, this signal, this force, sounded completely different ... She had once thought it had to do with her sensitive hearing, but after her recent discovery ... She had a bad feeling. *Maybe I should bring some other felinaes here? A few felinaes from Etheri, that is*… she thought, staring into the dense metallic forest. She had a package on the skimmer, her cardboard box. She left Melog at the dock. Her companion reacted extremely badly to the aura of the island. He felt the taking away the will of life aura much more strongly than the others, but at the same time he felt the bliss the music evoked in her. It was painfully overwhelming for him, as she had learned at Entrapta's wedding party. That's why she left him on the skimmer, let him guard her treasure. She had one more request for Entrapta, though she wasn't entirely sure she wanted to make it. Now she was hesitant to know the truth. Adora this

knowledge did not bring happiness, nor will it bring her. But she had to know the truth to know who she really was. And where is she from.

She stood in front of Castle Mysterio's gates and eyed them suspiciously. The castle was weird and chaotic…and overwhelming. A clear combination of the visions of both builders. As she approached, two stalked cybernetic eyes stretched out towards her and studied her.

„Object recognized as Grand Marshal Catra. Status: Friendly. Start the onboarding process. said a voice from the door. she sighed. Entrapta never knew when her inventions became disturbing. The gates swung open with a bang. There stood an old Galactic Horde bot dressed in livery and with a smile glued on. But sometimes it's good that no one lives here, otherwise a few people would run away screaming at the sight. It is said that Entrapta once had a robot uprising. She hoped it wouldn't happen here.

„So... Will you let me in? Inside? Will you take me to Entrapta?" she asked uncertainly, and the robot looked at her and turned away. She shrugged and followed him.

Castle Mysterio wasn't as cursed and crazy a maze as Entrapta's old home, though there was a hint of chaos here. Muting protecting against the signal from the interior made it seem to be quite a cozy place. She went through several rooms until she came to a large workshop, or maybe a laboratory? She had no idea. Suddenly, from between the tables, something ran towards her and, wrapping its hair around her legs and torso, climbed high enough to look her straight in the face. A blue-haired, perhaps three-year-old but very large child with purple eyes and a white complexion pressed his forehead to hers.

„Aunt Catra!" Kid chuckled, showing sharp teeth.

„Hi Child!” She responded by showing her equally sharp fangs. Well… Hordak and Entrapta made a baby before they got married, in a very literal sense. It was created in a laboratory and grew in a tank ... For now, it was simply referred to as the Child. According to Etherian custom, children chose their names and pronouns at the age of seven. Sometimes the result was Mikah and sometimes Castaspella. There was a big age difference between Glimmer's father and aunt, and little Castaspella chose that name because she believed it would make her as great a sorceress as her big brother.

After a while, the person she liked much less appeared behind the table. Hordak, former ruler of the Etherian Horde, watched her with his always sour face. The genetic therapy had served him well, and he no longer needed the power armor. Not that he didn't wear it, especially here at work in the interior of the island. His current outfit had two extra servo arms that probably made him as multi-tasking as his spouse.

„Is there Entrapta?” she asked, trying to sound completely indifferent.

„She will come soon.” he said briefly. The child grabbed the bars suspended from the ceiling with his hair and "ran" towards his father and threw himself on his shoulders. Hordak smiled at his child. She was almost offended by it. *You have deprived hundreds of orphans of a happy childhood, and now you play the role of a beloved husband and daddy! Good for you* she thought venomously. The child climbed on Hordak's back and wrapped its hair around his shoulders.

„Daddy, can Aunt Catra stay?” asked the child. His father replied with clear sarcasm in his voice.

„Aunt Catra is very busy as Grand Marshal of Etheria”

Behind her, Entrapta came out of the ventilation shaft and she started talking in an excited voice.

„Catra! Great that you are! I just wanted to show you something unusual about these artifacts we took from Horde Prime's vault. You know, the ones that no one claimed because they belonged to the civilizations that he destroyed and no one was left behind. Because you see, one of them… „

„Maybe another time, for now we have to fly to Netosa because ..." she tried to interrupt inventor, but she did not succeed, because she shouted with delight.

„Oh, She wants to show us the armory!

She blinked twice, trying to comprehend what the former Lady of Dryll was talking about.

„The armory?"

"Yes, her grandmother's armory, where a lot of ancient weapons from the time of the First Ones or just after they left, which if they fell into the wrong hands could cause damage on an unimaginable scale!" And I can test it all. her friend said with unstoppable excitement.

She tried very hard not to look at Hordak, because if she saw the curiosity or triumph on his face, she wouldn't know what she would do. But he spoke on his own, in a surprisingly thoughtful voice.

„Shadow Weaver mentioned this once and always pushed us to capture Netosa alive after she failed to... get all the information during the interrogation of her father.

She felt shivers down her spine because she knew what an interrogation by a dark sorceress would look like. She looked sharply at her former superior. He looked to the side as if confused. She snorted in contempt.

"Then pack up..." she wanted to say, but Entrapta cut her off.

"I'm always packed, because if someone needs to solve a problem with advanced technology, secret technology, First Ones technology, anything related to technology, I'm called. That's why I always have to be ready to go." The lilac-haired woman said happily. If it had been anyone else, she would have taken her words as a reproach, but it still hurt. "I need to be here more often, even if it means running into Hordak". Entrapta whistled, and a trunk-sized bot with six legs ran to her. He was hung with packages, had a strange triangular head with three eyes, one on each corner of the triangle.

„Catra, meet Alice. Alice meet Catra." She pointed at her and the robot. She sighed seeing another contraption created by Entrapta, but smiled and politely greeted the bot, which started making strange noises reminiscent of barking.

„She can be a little nervous around strangers, but you'll make friends! I have all the equipment I need to explore the armory there. I've been waiting for Netosa to invite me for a long time! Hordak, take care of the Child I'll be gone for a day or a week." she said. Excited, she ran out of the room.

She just hoped her friend knew what she was doing...

Melog greeted her at the dock. He jumped on her and licked her. He told her he was afraid he wouldn't come back. That it will unite with the island. She shivered because it matched what Adora and the others were saying, but then he added, "Island Waiting." She shivered again, but tried not to ask. She wasn't sure if he could explain it to her anyway, or if she wanted to know. Entrapta, meanwhile, made herself comfortable on the skimmer, but she could make herself comfortable even on Beast Island or in the Horror Zone.

„Listen Entrapta, I have a package there, I would like you to take a look at its contents, just be ..." She turned around sharply when

she heard the sound of the box being opened. „BE CAREFUL!” she shouted, but Entrapta gently held her card, eyeing it suspiciously.

„I'm always careful. After all, I work with explosives and explosions are pretty rare.” She began to turn the card over, more and more confused. "It's definitely cardboard. Made of cellulose." She looked at it, not understanding why she should examine an ordinary cardboard box. She sighed and said.

„This is the cardboard box Adora found me in.”

Entrapta widened her eyes. Which made her cry with excitement.

„It's as cute as it is tragic.” -

„Yes, I know it best.” She closed her eyes and put her fingers to her forehead. „Just read the writings.”

The lilact-haired woman read the inscriptions silently, making „Aw” only once at the sight of an apple. Finally she asked.

„Kesler? Haven't heard of this place”

She smiled sadly.

“No one on all Etheria heard.”

She heard a sharp intake of air and heard Entrapta lunge at her. She didn't have to open her eyes not to see him staring at her. That's what she feared.

„Entrapto... Please... It's me, still the same Catra, don't look at me like that. At least not you.” she said in a broken voice. When she opened her eyes, tears ran down her cheeks and she saw her friend watching her with concern instead of the fascination she expected. She placed her hands on her shoulder

„But it's wonderful ... Think, of all beings on Etheria, except for my husband, only you and Adora were not born here. You must have arrived here at the same time. You came to the same place

and found yourself. Can you imagine what an incredible twist of fate this is? How special are you both?!”

And then she burst out laughing. All her life she had envied Adora that everyone could see her uniqueness, and now…now it terrified her. She was afraid that everyone, especially Adora, would stop seeing her as she was. That she would lose everything she had worked so hard for. She gave the helm to Entrapta and went to cry herself cuddled up to Melog.

Tyrants will fall

They were approaching the monastery, which was on a half-terraformed planet, covered with dry plains covered with lichens and mosses. The air was breathable, but thin as in the high mountains. It was hard to breathe here without the environmental armor, but Captain Moonshadow it didn't make much of a difference anyway. And so the mask always helped her breathing. She spread her cybernetic wings and landed on the lichen crunching under her feet as Tonado, Gydwa and Kaert climbed down the rope. Skittermander was as full of absolute faith as ever in his captain, but the morale of the rest of her officers had waned when they received a message from this Horde Ultimate. She herself was confused. She remembered the Invader's appearance, and when she saw him on the video, she felt… sad? He couldn't end up like this. Hers was vengeance. No one had the right to take her revenge. This Mind Eater… What was she? Had she given her enemy a fate a hundred times worse than anything she could think of? The questions suddenly multiplied so much. And she didn't have time to consider all the possibilities. Her crew was concerned about possibility of meeting the Lady of Chaos, as was she, but she suspected who the woman was. *She stole my sword and sold her soul to demons. It would be fitting for such a treacherous seed* she thought. She was ready to fight even a demon princess to reclaim her inheritance and satisfy her hunger for revenge... But her crew wasn't prepared for that. They could fight the Azlanti and space monsters, and ultimately the Hell Knights. But will he be able to persuade them to set foot on a world devoured by demons? To come face to face with the heirs of one who burned entire nations to ashes? Who would be reasonable to oppose such a person?

For now they were calm, they hadn't met any threat yet, the whole journey was actually more peaceful than usual, but she knew that the moment of truth would come after the first clash. She agreed to help search the monastery to keep her crew busy,

because when the pirates got bored, they came up with stupid ideas. Besides, she hoped that perhaps they would get some information about what was going on here. Treasures were also important. The monasteries were wealthy, so there was a chance that they could get his riches, which would boost the morale of the crew…if someone hadn't already seized them. She wasn't sure what attacked the monastery was interested in his property. After receiving Horde Prime's looping monologue, she assumed that he was unlikely to be interested in material goods ... So much the better for her crew.

Deadly Sword of Burning Fury landed near the monastery. Seeing his crew, she smiled beneath the mask. Dragonkin, a human girl with orcish amulets, and an elf tattooed with flaming roses stood in a cluster, watching her carefully and trying to look as threatening as possible, which they managed not too badly. The white-haired girl stood a bit to the side, looking at her scared, apparently she had never seen a real pirate. The last of the young people was not visible, but seeing the red dot on Gydwa's temple, she understood what she was doing. She really liked these kids. Maybe because she was once a mother herself. She didn't remember what had happened to her daughter, she only knew that she had been taken from her once, but nothing else... She must have met a terrible fate that she shouldn't know.

„You don't have to be afraid of me. I do not break or even bend the letter of my contracts. I'm an honest pirate. You can tell the feline girl she doesn't have to aim at my second mate."

Hearing her words, Gydwa started looking around looking for a shooter, which made the pirate even more amused. The captain of the ship waved his hand, and from above the bushy lichen stood a figure dressed in the cloak of an Akitonian nomad,. This time the feline girl wore a hood on her head and a mask and goggles on her face. She ran up to them waving this strange mechanical prosthetic.

„Hey Moonshadow. Sorry for aiming at the hammerhead, but it's so big it's begging to be shot at. I would always keep it next to

you, because she attracts fire very well.”

Tonado nodded, and Gydwa shot the girl a murderous look.

„I will take this into account.” She answered the girl and together they approached the rest of the group. There was their captain, this Bina, who watched anxiously at the structure before them. She looked like a cunning woman, but she seemed to care about her unruly bunch. The great half-elf mercenary stood and clenched her armored fist significantly. She knew many mercenaries, had some in her crew, and killed many in her war against the Azlanti. This one, however, seemed a bit more decent than most, like someone who only cared about money. Verthani was an archaeologist who had tricked Kaert and Gydwa, which amused her somewhat. Well, her second mate wasn't the best at recruiting crew members, especially when they weren't dim-witted killers. Rechiza was a witchwarper and looked unlucky, which was actually common in this profession. They both seemed to be in the right place for this type of jon, and so did Ysoka-technician. Lady Cala, however, puzzled her more. Was she just a bored aristocrat going on such a ridiculous quest? She saw in her the immense, unstoppable confidence that all mad adventurers had, but there was something else to her. A certain... authority... Her high opinion of herself seemed to stem from an awareness of her own power, as if she possessed a mighty and unstoppable force. And she was supposed to be just a pampered damsel who had heard too many stories about this Mara and had taken on this perilous quest. Perhaps behind this decision was this strange gloomy elf with gray skin, who was looking at the monastery thoughtfully. This woman… as soon as she heard her voice, she felt a strange pressure on her temple that made her slightly dizzy. She felt as if she knew this woman, but she couldn't. According to Azlanti information, Etheria, her lost home, was hidden somewhere in an inaccessible Hidden Realm. "Are you like me a runaway from my home? Another victim of the invader?" she thought as she stared at her grim face. Nothing else suggested that she should beware of this woman more than any other mystic. but she decided she should watch Miss Daisy anyway. Well, another reason to travel with this strange group. The last

was standing next to the other elven sorceress, a strange and talkative elven woman who was trying to explain something to him, and he was trying to listen, not understanding her at all. He had the face and voice of an invader, and even his name, though she couldn't remember what it sounded like until it came out of his mouth. But at the same time, he was by no means one. They knew each other, though, if she understood the context of what he was saying. So he will lead her to her revenge.

She looked at the convent building. Even from this distance, she could see signs of fighting on its walls, and its metallic gold dome typical of Serenae worshipers was melted in one spot, but the damage had been light, so the resistance were probably minimal. Well, what could you expect from monks living somewhere on a planet forgotten by the gods. There were gardens around it, which indicated that they had some area-based system to create better living conditions that was still operational. Their scanners showed that the underground complex was huge, perhaps built over centuries. This gave hope that someone could hide there after the attack, or that some of the treasures had not been found. No doubt life signals were detected in the monastery, though something was interfering with the scanners. What will they have to search themselves. A drone flew towards them, hovered and began to speak in a metallic voice.

"The area is clear, I haven't detected anything dangerous on the surface, nothing bigger than a scorpiorat."

Monshadow saw out of the corner of her eye that the girl with the orc amulets, I think her name was Lilka, shuddered.

„So, shall we go in?” Bina asked.

„There's nothing to wait for.” answered the burgundy-haired woman. "Vengeance Awaits Me"

Eti felt bad… I mean, she never really felt good. There was always that sadness in her that cast a shadow over her world. He was like a fog through which she had to break through all her life ... Or not, others saw the world through the fog, she perceived reality more sharply and truthfully than others. All ugliness and meanness shone in her eyes brighter than the sun in the sky. Also her own meanness. Recently, she wanted to do good and hurt her friend, her friends. Sometimes she did that, hurting others for no reason. Not even for pleasure or anger, just ... So that they could see the world as she saw it, to see her as she is. She squeezed her temples and growled softly. She felt the breath of Rainy Days on her neck. For now, however, distant, but slowly approaching. This mission might make her forget all about it. On the surface of the planets, when she was busy with something, she always felt better than during those long flights in spaceships. New sensations, the need to make decisions, adrenaline and fear made her forget that reality is nasty and mean.

She also felt strange because she didn't go ahead scouting as she usually did. Invisible, with a rifle in her hand, she had the power, she was indestructible and invincible. But she felt good walking in the company of her friends, even though she knew she should feel ashamed. For what she did. Itel also seemed ashamed, as if she had done something wrong, it was only her fault. Sparkle Fingers was as cheerful and happy as ever, but she sensed sadness in her, and Fist gave her and Itel such looks as if she wanted to crush their heads. Yes, she was guilty, there was no doubt about it.

They found themselves in a garden covered with fruit bushes and flowers. Sparkle Fingers plucked some sweet red fruit and handed it to her and Wormdak The white-skinned alien accepted the treat, though he had been oddly withdrawn and sullen since receiving that idiotic transmission from one of his brothers, but she replied

„I don't eat fruit, I just don't feel sweet taste. But if you see one of these scorpiorats, tell me, I'd eat one grilled.”

Rosie nodded seriously, but Lilka spoke in a frightened voice.

„And warn us! I don't want someone to bite me.

Itel stopped, looked over her shoulder, and said.

"But scorpiorat venom is harmless, it can only hurt you a little."

"And what if I turn into a scorpion man afterward, that is a scorpion woman?" Lila asked.

Itel looked at her for a moment with a twitching eyelid.

„Lilka, first of all, scorpiorat venom doesn't turn you into scorpion people, second. There's no such thing as scorpion people.”

Then Eti felt an irresistible urge to interject.

„I'm sorry, Itel, but what you're saying doesn't make sense.” she said, and when Itel looked at her in disbelief, she continued, "There are billions of planets in our galaxy alone, and countless intelligent races. Based on statistics alone, it is easy to prove that there may be not only scorpion-men and men-scorpion but even scorpion-men-rats.” she explained, and Lilka moaned loudly.

„Why are you scaring her!” the Solarian shouted at her.

„I'm sorry, but I see absolutely no reason to keep Lilka ignorant. I prefer to warn her about what the world is like and explain to you how statistics work, because you clearly don't understand it.”

„What are you even talking about… „ Itel started, but Wrongdak interjected.

"I'm friends with a scorpion woman…" he said, but Itel turned to him.

„Why are you interfering! Nobody asked your opinion!” she screamed, making the white-skinned man back away. Bina approached them, blushing with anger. Clearly she pissed someone off again.

"One more word and you'll remember me. Eti, stop being smartass and talking nonsense... - their... kaptai started yelling at them, but Eti cut her off.

"Actually, the term 'talking nonsense' is…" she was saying, but Bina didn't let her finish.

„Just one more word." she threatened, and Eti only forced herself to remain silent with the greatest effort of will. "And you, Itel, are no better, because you yell at Mister Wrongdak for no reason." The burgundy-haired woman sighed, rubbing her forehead. "Listen, I don't know what happened between the two of you, and it's best for you two to sort it out between you two, but unfortunately, we're just getting into a place where the Devils and Daemons know what's waiting for us, so take it easy for yourself instead of doing YOURSELF shame in front of pirates, mercenaries and aristocrats.

Itel pursed her lips and looked away, suppressing her anger, but Eti could see that her friend was embarrassed. She felt ashamed herself too, obviously not because of what Stinka might think, because it was like caring what a cockroach thought, but she knew that she had hurt others, both now and before. Fist and Grimmy were looking at her intently, and Sparkle Fingers acted as if she was complicit herself. She immediately hung her head, and together they set out again towards the convent.

The closer we got, the more lush the gardens became. Nut, apple and olive trees also grew here. She didn't like apples, but she plucked some nuts, which she intended to smash with a metal hand. They walked in quite uncomfortable silence until finally Alatar spoke.

„And what is the difference between a scorpion man and a man scorpion.

Eti looked at him askance.

"That's obvious, dear Drakey. A scorpion man has a human top and a scorpion bottom, a man scorpion has a scorpion top and a human bottom... Or vice versa.

„And what is it when there is a big scorpion, but it has the head and hands of a man and a lot of human legs.” Lilka asked with absolute seriousness in her voice. The whole group stopped abruptly. Itel took a deep breath and spoke slowly.

"I don't know, and I don't even want to imagine it." Where do you come up with such ideas?!

Lilka shrugged, but Eti decided to interject

„This creature straight from the worst nightmares ... it's cool.” Lilka, what kind of tail would it have ...” - he asked. The red-haired girl began to think about her answer, and Itel was about to start yelling at her again, but then Miss Daisy approached their group, obviously greatly amused by something.

„Miss Eti is right about one thing, „ said the gloomy sorceress, and Eti, hearing her name in one sentence with the word miss, was simply speechless. „ The galaxy is full of wonders,Great and terrible, beyond our wildest imagination. I found out for myself when I left my home planet. For example, on my planet, dragons were fairy-tale creatures. And here I am, having barely left my provincial Carurystal, and here I met Mister Alatar, perhaps not a classic dragon, but highly technically gifted.” She smiled mysteriously. „Yes, the universe is full of strange things. Be assured that you must expect the unexpected and accept that you will never be able to prepare for everything, and that sooner or later your luck will run out and then we will have to suffer the consequences of our actions.” Grimm voice became quiet and sad. "Therefore, do not think much about the future, do not worry about what will come, for we are all but leaves in the wind... Just be careful not to be swept away by the black wind."

Eti looked at her and smiled slightly, which drew incredulous looks from her friends, patted her back and said.

„Welcome to the truth-seeing club.”

There were times when Bina wanted to strangle her charges. These kids were so loved sometimes, after all they had been through, after the horror of being invaded by the most fearsome force in the galaxy, after the great betrayal they had suffered from those who where supposed to protected the weakest, who called themselves heroes, still had good hearts. They were able to help others without demanding anything in return. But they were so incredibly annoying. They were arguing about absolute crap, almost punching each other. They always pounced on those stronger than themselves. Itel and her fanatical hatred pushed everyone into more and more trouble. Eti did not think about the consequences of her actions at all, Lilka could go crazy or panic for any reason, and Alatar could be mean and conceited. Sometimes it felt like she was only one step, one word away from dropping it all and going her own way. However, she couldn't do that. She took the burden of looking after them on her shoulders and had to bear it until the very end, which might come much sooner than she wanted.

Now they were arguing about bloody scorpions, though she had a feeling it was about something else. Itel wanted more from Et than she wanted to give her, but Eti didn't understand that by sleeping with Itel, she was only fueling her hopes. And then there was that intern Rosie. Eti liked her surprisingly quickly, and Bina think it scared her, because in the meantime they had an argue. Well, there's one more place on her ship just in case. It also seemed that the girl would like it too, because she had no relatives, but for the time being, the three of them would get along with Itel and Eti and determine what their relationship should look like.

The gates of the monastery were open. Which was helpful, but also sinister. Made of gold-shining metal, they where covered with a relief depictingwith scenes that she couldn't fully decipher, but she thought she saw Iomadae there, which was nothing strange,

for the two goddesses were friends. Arkan-Tar studied the inscriptions carefully and curiously. She saw traces of laser gun shots on the gate. Captain Moonshadow stood beside her. The tall, masked pirate was awe-inspiring, as if she had a natural aura of authority around her. She wasn't sure if she liked the woman, but she certainly earned her respect.

„I have bad feelings.” Bina grunted.

"You always have a bad feeling when you're doing what I'm doing, unless you're crazy." The pirate captain gave her a sidelong look, and Bina saw amusement in her eyes.

"You've never had kids to take care of." she said firmly, and then she saw the pain in Moonshadow's eyes.

„How can you know that? You don't know who I was and how I became who I am. Everyone has a past and no one is born like me.” the Pirate snapped sharply, but Bina answered her with a wry smile.

„I don't know, it's a sad you didn't meet one of my sisters, but you're right, there's nothing to wait for. Whatever lurks inside, it certainly doesn't expect someone like us.”

The courtyard of the monastery looked a bit like a fairy tale. Flowers bloomed everywhere, though most of them were a bit wild, but that only added to the charm. There were several paths made of slabs made of colored stone. Somehow, the fountain was still functioning, the sound of which was pleasantly soothing. The only thing that marred the landscape was a tall white spire with a disturbing, alien appearance. She saw Wrongdak watching her carefully.

„It's the Horde Prime communications spire. It gave access to his communications network, and also allowed him to maintain a local offshoot of his hive mind, and controlled the droids... Here, too, the subjects could... watch Horde Prime transmit his will and

decrees to them.” he explained after a moment. Arkan-tar regarded the structure thoughtfully. She frowned, not trusting the scholar much, certainly less than the pirate.

„All right, now we have to make sure that there is no one alive here.” Bina said, and then Lilka clasped her hands together in a scream and screamed at the top of her lungs.

-„Hey, there's someone here! Let him come here. We certainly won't hurt him and we're just so cool!” Lilka waved the ax above her head. Half of those present looked at her with a mixture of surprise and annoyance, but the red-haired girl didn't care. She listened for a moment, then shook her head, spreading her hands helplessly.

„I guess they went away because if they didn't go, they would come to us, so I guess we have to go, since they don't want to come.”

To smother or to hug, that is the question thought Bina, sighing heavily.

Arak-tar was feeling better now, despite the presence of the pirates, especially one half-drow with a pleasant face and a nasty disposition. He found himself in his own environment. Abandoned buildings were his place of work. Uncovering their secrets was not only his profession, but also the purpose of his life, a passion to which he devoted himself. And this place held secrets, even the gate. They had been covered with relief depicting piece of myth he didn't know. At first he assumed that one of the inhertors legends was depicted there, which was not unheard of. Both Serenae and Iomadae and their churches were friends, so they often collaborated on many levels. But something strange happened here. The myth told the story of a great warrior, or perhaps a scholar, who distinguished herself in battle against the many enemies of her country or planet, and then received a holy sword, and for some unknown reason, began to replace her with

Iomadae ... Then Saint Serenia appeared, though he only guessed that, and then the story got even more confusing. Maybe if he had more time he would decipher it… Maybe he would come back here, the Serenae church would certainly be interested in recovering the lost monastery.

In the courtyard, he smiled seeing the spire and hearing Wrongdak's explanation.

„Maybe Doctor Quin and Rechiza and I will look for a computer control room. Some kind of terraforming device is operating here, so the power supply is definitely working.” Verthani said. Only Bina gave him a suspicious look, but he answered her with a friendly smile,

As soon as they left, Rechiza said.

„I don't like this place.”

Arkan'tar wondered if she was talking about the Monastery or the whole Zone.

„Well, a monastery like a monastery. In Akitona, I lived next to the Triune Monastery, where some kids went to study. This one is much bigger, but also much more boring.”

Arkan tar looked at the others and smiled, noticing that they weren't paying attention to them, he said.

"And you could break into that spire." He asked. Ysoka turned and looked at the structure Horde Prime had built

„Why not? I'm not a Hacker, but you seem to have good hacking gear, so that shouldn't be a problem. Just why do it?

Verthani smiled.

„As you heard from our friend Wrongdak, this structure was used to communicate with the entire Horde Prime network. Perhaps we could download the data and download it to our computer.” said

the scholar, and when Ysoka nodded, he added, "Perhaps it could also be used to amplify our signals and send a message to the Lord Admiral?"

Out of the corner of his eye, he saw Rechiza smiling.

„Itel, Bina, look at this! Alatar called. Bina and the elf ran to them and the captain hoped they found something to cheer her up. They had searched several buildings before. The interiors were mostly in such a state as if they had been recently abandoned. There were a few apartments for families, apparently monks were born and died here, and warehouses for gardening and farming equipment, and a pumping station to support the irrigation system, and so on. There were a few places, probably where resistance had been met, where was a mess, but generally, except for the signs of the passage of time, these places were left in perfect order. Virtually nothing had been looted or destroyed, as if the invaders didn't care about material possessions. Only residents. Even the Swarm was more greedy… She hoped Alatar hadn't stumbled upon something equally disturbing.

„What do you have there?{ she asked and walked over with Rlfka. Itel had grown up in the woods in a small settlement and, in Alatar's opinion, was very good at tracking. Eti was better and had an excellent sense of smell, but she was nowhere to be seen now.

"Traces…" he pointed at the footprints. She sighed mentally, cursing her luck. Itel looked at them carefully.

„I see traces of a large humanoids here. she said and called Wrongdak and examined his foot. “Yeah, they're clones and I think bots. They were here a few days ago. And there are fresher ones, three pairs, but they were probably smaller humanoids.” Itel explained matter-of-factly. Bina let out a whoosh of air. She wanted to call the others, but then Eti called them.

"Come here, there's something weird here."

Most of them ran after the feline girl's voice. She led them to the largest structure. It was a temple. It had many stained glass windows made of translucent glassdiamond, most often depicting flowers. There were many pews here, for at least a few hundred worshippers. There was an image of Iomadae on the ceiling, though it was hard to tell because it was burned away with lasers and other energy weapons. A lot of liturgical equipment has been left here, and even a wat of a golden altar. Moonshadow's comrades whistled at the sight, but when they looked at the statue towering above them, they fell silent. It depicted a tall robed clone with metal claws attached to his fingers. He had three eyes on one side of his face and was smiling triumphantly. At his feet lay a shattered statue of Serenae wearing a golden crown. Wrongdak stood behind them.

„It's him, it's Horde Prime. he said with a strange mix of fear and anger. She shivered because he really did remind her of her Father. The silence that fell was broken by Eti.

„He has a smile, like a guy who wants to show his puppies to the kids at the park.” said the feline girl. Everyone giggled. Dilayla in power armor approached the statue.

"Well, time to do something about that nasty face." Step aside. she said, and tapped her armored glove several times on the legs of the statue. First cracks appeared, and then the statue fell to the floor with a thud. As the dust cleared, Lady Cala said a few words thoughtfully. Seeing their questioning looks, she said in her always gentle voice.

„ It's an ancient phrase. It means "And tyrants will fall when in their pride they arouse the wrath of the true masters of the universe”

Rulers of the United Kingdoms

She woke up and wiped her tear-stained eyes. She saw Entrapta crouched beside her, doing some calculations on the datapad. It took her a moment to realize what that meant. She rushed to the helm.

"Calm down, i fitted the autopilot.” said the lilac-haired woman without breaking away from her work. She stopped struggling with the rudder and looked at Entrapta anxiously.

"That's mean you did for us autopilot when we were at the seaside... The one with the waves."She felt the hairs on her spine stand on end. Melog puffed up and turned blue with fear "Didn't you think we might fall into the water and drown?"

Entrapta looked at her.

„Unlikely. Horde skimmers have surprisingly high buoyancy, you wouldn't believe how high.”

"I don't believe…" she said quietly. Under her nose, but the inventor heard it anyway

„I can show you.” she said and reached for the helm to stop the vehicle. She stopped her friend in horror.

„NO! Please!” she said, looking around. They flew along the coast, and the shore was terrifyingly far away. She had forgotten that sometimes you had to be careful with your words when talking to Entrapta. „I believe you, but please don't tamper with the vehicles you fly without asking the other passengers, okay?”

„All right, I'll try to remember.” she said.

They were already approaching the realm of Spinnerella, actually the now unified kingdom of Spinnerella and Netossa. The former

country of the Wind Lady was called Windcrest, and her Wifes was called the Armoria. The Armoria was sworn to the Scorpions and hostile to Windcrest. Sometimes they even fought each other. Everything changed when Hordak arrived. The usurper king has seized power in the Kingdom of Scorpions, Netosa's grandmother stayed on side of his niece. Soon after, both countries fell to the Horde and both princesses spent almost thirteen years in Brightmoon waging war and caring for refugees. In Hordak's time, the locals were subjects of the Horde and contributed to the war effort by the sweat of their brow. Many fled to the free kingdoms, but others stayed here. As a cadet, she had little contact with people outside the capital, but as the right-hand to the ruler of the Fright Zone, she often read reports from there. If she remembered correctly, she screwed the screw there and forced the inhabitants to pour out seventh sweat in the production of weapons and food and the acquisition of raw materials. The Armoria in particular was burdened, for much of the Windcrest was picturesque windy hills, though there were many powerful wind traps, and even now many remain in use.

She did not like to return to the areas once occupied by the Horde. Everyone here knew her, sometimes in person. And they remembered her from her darkest period. She didn't think then that she would ever have to face the consequences of her actions, what she did to her own subordinates. Her friends could forgive her, Mikach could forgive her, but she knew it wouldn't be so easy with those she made them work beyond their means. More than once she had worried if she was better than Hordak. He escaped his responsibility to the Beast Island, she took refuge in Brightmoon, protected by the most important people in the galaxy. Seeing the settlement in the distance, she flattened her ears.

„Entrapta, could you put that autopilot on so it avoids any settlements.” She shyly asked her friend

Entrapta looked at her.

„The autopilot is connected to Susan.” the inventor began, but was interrupted.

„Susan?” she asked confused.

„The main autonomous satellite of Etheria. The basis of our satellite system.” – Entrapta answered

„We have a satellite system?” she asked confused. As Grand Marshal, she should probably know something about this.

„Yes, I even sent a message to Glimmer... Or maybe not? You know, I have a lot of work right now. Baby, communications network, early warning systems… It's a good thing Hordak's cooking, because I wouldn't have time for anything else.

She had to digest the vision of Hordak cooking for a moment before asking again.

"Then will Susan let us bypass the settlements?"

Entrapta nodded.

„Her autonomous Si has mapped the entire available part of the planet and can send data to the navigation system I have installed here, so she does not need a remote control. I just don't see any reason why we should avoid any settlements. I would buy some things here in the local workshop, which I would take to the island, and apparently they make such tiny cheese balls in spices ...” She raised her hand to interrupt her friend before she gained momentum

„Listen Entrapta. I'd like to stay here somewhere, maybe take a shower, use a real bathroom, but you know, this is former Horde territory, or maybe Horde occupied.” she said, and seeing that the former Mrs. Drylu stared at her without understanding, she began to explain. "Look, the people here were once Hordak's subjects, but at the end of the war when you…" She regretted bringing up the subject. "I just don't want them to see me, not after what i did to them. In Brightmoon, I'm just one of the many Horde

soldiers who finally made the right choice. Here I was someone whose wrath made everyone tremble, who forced them to isanely hard work. Alone… You know what she used to be like. she said, trying to hold back tears from her eyes. Entrapta looked at her understandingly.

„Yes, I can avoid settlements. It's not a problem…" She thought for a moment. "You know, Hordak also speaks like that, only in different words. Because others don't see him the way I do. A great scientist, a brilliant engineer, a wonderful father... The best partner I could have had." she said thoughtfully. "And that's why he doesn't want to leave the island, and I want us to be together, so I'm with him. I… I understand that he has done a lot of bad things in the past and it will be difficult for others to forgive him. I would love for that to happen someday…" She became sad, but then she smiled and said. "I don't think anyone else hates you." The Fright Zone was a scary place. Its briought out the worst in others, everyone knows it. Me too." said the former Lady of Dryl. She sighed loudly and said.

"Perhaps you're right, but I don't feel like proving it right now. Especially now after what I found out. She rubbed her forehead and added. "And don't tell anyone about our discovery. I... I have to sort things out in my head. And I'd rather you didn't tell anyone about it. I want Adora to know about all this first."

Entrapta stared at her for a long moment, then asked cautiously.

„But Hordak... He is my assistant. O n needs to know about this."

For a moment she considered asking her friend to lie to the former lord of the Etherian Horde, but changed her mind. It might be too hard for Entrapta. She didn't want to cause any more trouble. Besides, what harm could come from Hordak finding out the truth about her origins? He wouldn't tell anyone anyway, no one would even listen to him. It might even be amusing to find out how little he knew about those he ruled. That Adora wasn't the only one with a secret. And he had no idea, as always. Of

course, it would be much nicer if Shadow Weaver found out. She smiled grimly at the thought and replied.

„You can tell him. It won't change anything. Absolutely anything.

Well, they washed up in a bucket of water and pooped in the woods, which reminded her of some of the Best Friend Squad successful trips to some wild planets. It was dangerous then, but it was a wonderful time. Maybe after the wedding, he and Adora would go to some of the wildest areas of Etheria, maybe they would even convince Glimmer and Bow to participate? After all, the queen is entitled to vacation, right?

Windcrest, despite many years of occupation, has not suffered significant damage or contamination, especially in comparison to the Fright Zone. When the magic was unleashed, after the Heart was destroyed, the forests that had been cut grew back and the hills turned green again. It was a picturesque place, perfect for a romantic picnic. It's worth considering, maybe she'll go here with Adora? And they will eat those spicy cheese balls...

The princesses of the united kingdoms lived in a newly built mansion on the border of the two countries. Netossa's headquarters was razed to the ground during the siege during the early clashes with the Horde, and Windcrest had a wandering court that simply moved to Brightmoon… at least what was left of it after an ambush organized by the Usurper King himself. He must have been a „wonderful” individual, she was glad she hadn't met him, though Hordak still remembered him fondly.

Once, the inhabitants of both kingdoms were in conflict and often fought with each other. However, after three decades of living in both realms, both those who fled to Brightmoon and those living under occupation became friends. This is how common hardships and miseries work. Now, actually, the bigger conflict was between the former refugees and the occupied. Well, she didn't envy the princesses' hardships of power.

The court of both kingdoms, the manor towered over a silvery lake, surrounded by short trees with silver-blue leaves. It was quite pretty, though the mix of burgundy and white was conspicuous from a distance. A small Galactic Horde ship hung nearby, but repainted in the colors of the Star Islands, probably Ruby, judging by its intense red color. Spinnerella and Netossa apparently had visitors. She parked in front of the vast mansion and got out with Melog and Entrapta with Alice. The purple-haired woman looked around curiously, and she knocked. It was opened by a goat person, who immediately stiffened at the sight of her. She looked painfully at Entrapta. "That's what I was talking about."

„Is there Princess Spinnerella and Princess Netossa? she asked, trying to smile as friendly as possible.

"Of course, the ladies of the united kingdom are receiving a visitor, but of course they will make time for Grand Marshal Catra and Princess Entrapta." he said and led them inside. Inside, she saw a clone in livery vigilantly observing the surroundings. She saw ceramic images of moons on the walls, a rather strange custom common throughout Etheria to hang them in various parts of the house to ensure good luck.

Seeing them, Spinnerella got up from the tea table and hugged her.

„Nice of you to visit us. We've been waiting for you.” said the lady of the winds. The two children, the feline boy and the girl Seihe also hugged her. Both queens of the united kingdoms adopted them. They also had a baby of their own, and judging by Spinnerell's rounded belly, they were expecting another. They were making up for the years of war, as were most of Etheria's inhabitants. After a while, Spinny went to say hello to Entrapta, who was trying to say hello to the clone, but he was reserved.

„Ah, Shadow Weaver ward!” She heard a hard, hoarse voice. Repulsed, she tensed, but refrained from drawing her claws out. Melog, however, put his ears down and began wagging his tail

nervously. She looked in the direction from which the voice came and saw a woman in a wheelchair, quite old-fashioned, but very intricately made. She had fiery red hair, slightly unkempt. She was quite attractive, but the left half of her body was gray as if dead. She smirked half of her mouth.

„Do you recognize her work? Apparently, you were quite close... Before you decided to take her place, of course.”

I don't like her already She thought, but tried to answer as calmly as possible.

„I'll say the same thing I recently told her sister... Yes, she had a family... Shadow Weaver didn't raise anyone, she only conditioned and I doubt if she had anyone close to her in her lousy life. In fact, she had always cared only for herself.” she sighed heavily. „Who do I have the pleasure of talking to?” she asked, although she guessed the answer.

„I am Halo, one of the Sisters Star, Grand Marshal Catra. I'm sorry that we haven't had the opportunity to meet in recent years, but I hope that we will be able to make up for it.”

Wonderful she thought.

"Halo said she'd be at Glimmer and Bow's wedding…and your and Adora's, of course." Spinnrela said looking at her apologetically.

Even better

„This is very surprising news. I thought you and your sister seceded from the Kingdom of Etheria. she asked a bit suspiciously. She tried to be kind, but she had no patience with this woman despite her condition. Halo smiled, and it was a particularly nasty smile.

„Politics should not make us forget about courtesy and mutual respect.” She looked at Entrapta coldly. “Of course, that doesn't mean we're backing down on our demands. We will get our justice eventually, it's just a matter of time.”

There was an awkward silence. Spinnerella tried to be polite, but it was hard when one guest was threatening the others.

„I will not allow my guests to be insulted in my house. Hello. We're friends, but…” Lady Wind said coldly. But Entrapta said.

„That's okay” and tried to smooth things over as best she could. She ran over to the cart and looked at it.

„You know, without the slightest problem you could connect an electric drive here, with the right tools it would take me no more than a quarter of an hour ...” she began to speak quickly

„Go away! Halo growled, but Entrapta continued.

"And when I get home, I'll build an anti-gravity cart, like the Horde tanks, only much smaller, of course, and..." She didn't finish as Halo screamed.

„GET OUT!”

Entrapta jumped back sharply as if scalded. She too, even from this distance, felt the wave of pain that spread with the woman's voice. Melog turned red, emanating from her rage. She pulled out her claws, and the clone stood up and glared at her menacingly. Spinnerella motioned to the children to move away and assumed a fighting stance herself. Entrapta looked at Sister Star confused and scared. She happened to be in the heat of the fight, but this time someone hurt the purple-haired woman at the moment when she wanted to help someone sincerely and selflessly. *I treated her like that once, it should never happen again* Halo looked around confused and ashamed.

"I'm sorry, I shouldn't have reacted so… intensely. After… What Shadow Weaver did to me, my power has changed and I don't always fully control it.” said the woman in the wheelchair and signaled her bodyguard to rest. She took a deep breath and also retracted her claws, and the melogue took on its usual color.

“That woman left her damn mark on all of us. Fortunately, she is no more, and we can all let our wounds heal.” she said, hoping she sounded wise and conciliatory. Halo looked at her curiously.

„You really believe that... that she's gone…” Sister star leaned one hand on the side of the stroller and almost stood up.

„You naive child. You don't know what I know. A great darkness hides among the stars, and beings as old as time itself watch us, weaving their intrigues. Who is merely a shadow cannot truly die. I tell you, the dead will walk among the living.” she said. She smiled with a mixture of indulgence and contempt, but felt a shiver run down her spine. Spinnerella looked at Halo sympathetically and said.

"Children, take Marshal Catra and Princess Entrapta to mamy Netossa?"

The kids, already scared by the Halo outburst, followed them with great pleasure.

On the way, the children introduced themselves to them. The feline boy was called Greypaw and the girl Seihe Quickling. The boy spoke to her, clearly admiring her, while Quickling told Entrapta about their life at the manor. They both cuddled up to Melog, who seems to like it. They were cute, but watching Greypaw made her even more aware of how different he was from other Etheria felines. Much less hair, differently spaced ears, a more human face… things that no one else would pay attention to. At least on this planet. In other places, things like species mattered a lot more.

They found Netossa on a court located on a hill a little behind the house, where she practiced catching balls in the net. It was only here that she saw a few guardsmen, though she guessed that there must be a few more in the house. She felt a twinge of uneasiness, but quickly dismissed it. The war is finally over, and even Lonnie with her People's Rebellion won't make the people of Etheria live in fear… She wasn't sure if she believed it or was just

trying to convince herself. Netossa embraced the children and greeted them.

„Hi Entrapta, Hi Catra, it's great that you're here. I've been packed for two days. she said, and Entrapta whistled. Alice ran out, preferring not to know where the bot was while they were talking.

„I'm already packed too. I can't wait to see your grandmother's armory. Apparently, she had such inventions there ... maybe even the doomsday weapon ... „ Entrapta squealed with delight, but at the sight of her friends' looks, she added. „Of course, everything will be used for peaceful purposes!”

Netossa sighed looking at them seriously.

„I have no idea, it's there. I've only been there once as a little girl. My grandmother then gave me my bracelet.” She pointed to a device for throwing power nets. “Actually, I don't know where Now might be”. she said with obvious embarrassment.

"What do you mean by Now might be?" she asked uncertainly.

„I don't know how to explain it… The Armory just appeared when we summoned it.” Netossa explained.

"You mean some vehicle that came when called?" Entrapta asked curiously. „Maybe a spaceship? Can you imagine Catra? Another Spaceship of the First Ones! Darla will have a brother or sister!” The inventor's voice became more and more excited.

"The spaceship can be nice. Darla's not that bad, „she thought, relieved.

Netossa shook her head.

„No... It was just a crystal gate that appeared when summoned. Inside was a large armory, in which resided a being called The Armorer. She gave us or sometimes even created what she considered necessary for us. Now I think it must have been the AI.”

„Oh, finally I will meet the real advanced AI of the First Ones! Can you imagine what we can learn from her from the next Light Hope. Entrapta radiated delight

She groaned. She'd never met Light Hope directly, but she had been rummaging through her head, bringing out her worst and most painful memories, nearly driving her insane. Compared to this bitch, Horde Prime was a butcher compared to a surgeon. Now she was dealing with another creation of the First Ones, perhaps just as dangerous and insane.

" I don't like it very much, I won't hide it. Open that door and let's get this over with." she said, dropping her ears low, and Melog clung to the ground, taking on the blue color of fear.

„There's only one problem. My grandmother gave the key to Frosta mother and the summoning device to the Star Sisters to keep it out of the hands of the Horde."

Catra groaned.

"You've met Halo before, haven't you?" she winced. "That's why we invited her here, though I prefer not to talk to her. Me and Pulsar filtered a bit... Before I met Spinny! And then, after the battle, I visited sisters on their island, and Halo called me a coward and said that's because of my cowardice she was maimed." Netossa said. "That's why I prefer not to talk to her."

„I'm not surprised. She called me a Shadow Weaver ward today, though she's not the first. A few days ago, I met the shadow lady's sister."

Netossa widened her eyes.

„Did she have a family?" said the ruler of Armoria incredulously.

„Yes." She nodded and briefly told her about the meeting with Midnight Mask. Netossa uttered a very long and extremely colorful string of curses that stung her cat ears. The mystery of Glimmer vocabulary has been solved. Fortunately, the children did not hear

anything, because together with Entrapta they were teaching Alice and Melog to fetch balls. Her companion, as soon as he noticed that she noticed his behavior, approached her embarrassed.

„Entrapta, we are going to the Kingdom of Snow.”

The inventor jumped with delight.

Remember our trip to the North Reach?" she said and squealed. "Too bad Scorpia isn't with us."

„I remember ... I'm going to freeze my tail again.” She sighed. "It's going to be a long journey."

Netossa smiled cheekily.

„Not that long, you'll take a Silverwing.”

Welcome to the wide universe.

Tallstar jumped as she felt the entire building shake. Her siblings did the same. They looked at each other surprised.

„What do you think it was?” Starla asked, reassuring Glory.

"I'm not sure…" Jewelstar said, examining the ceiling as if searching for cracks. I hope no one is firing here." Do you remember Aquarius?”

Tallstar clenched her cybernetic prosthetic fist.

„It's hard for us to forget. I hope all of this doesn't come crashing down on us. 0 she said anxiously looking into the darkness stretching out before them. They had two night vision goggles, and the Jewelstar's eye had a similar feature, but they weren't the best. Those strange creatures that Wrongdak flew away with once sold them a perfect one, but they traded it for information about the location of the Back-up with Horde Prime's consciousness, which turned out to be false. Maybe we need to look for the planet of these creatures ... They probably have more and better equipment.

„You know what I thought? Why don't we go on vacation when we're done with this place? There's supposed to be a big victory party on Etheri and all... Maybe we'll rest there for a few months, maybe even a year?" Starla suggested, stroking Glory's head.

Jewelstar winced.

„’We still have a lot of work ahead of us.” he said grimly.

Talstar rolled her eyes.

„What work?! Horde Prime was destroyed five years ago. And we're still fighting like nothing has changed. I'm sorry, it's

changed. Now we have two tyrants… No, I'm sorry, I was wrong. We've got eight crazy tyrants and a hell of a lot of local pirates and bandits, not to mention Bellum freaks.”

Her brother snorted.

„Horde Ultimate and Heavenly Brothers are mere shadows of Prime.”

Talstar nodded.

„Yes, and that's why we should think about retirement. Or at least on vacation. And so the three of us won't win the peace just like we didn't win the war. We helped foment a galactic rebellion, wonderful, but we won't do much more. At least Icarus is finally free.”

"There's nothing left for us on Icarus anyway. And many innocents still suffer under the yoke of his heirs”.

She groaned helplessly.

„We can't save everyone. I know you'll never get over our loss, but it's time to move on. It's a matter for others. Those of Etheria are rumored to want to form a galactic alliance. Maybe it's better that we somehow use our knowledge and skills to help, instead of blindly crashing all over the universe.”

The argument went to Jewelstar, but he pressed his lips together hard, as always it takes a while for him to agree with her.

„You know, why don't we postpone such discussions for later and check this place out? Preferably ASAP?" Starla interjected.

She was right. Their new ship, which they named the Honor in… honor of their Etherian friends, detected a signal coming from this place where they were calling for help. It was old, but there was no ship around for years, and they had nothing else to do anyway. For six months they had been wandering from one port to another, looking for something to do… or rather, a purpose. Most

of the former rebels abandoned the fight or joined the various armed formations formed by the newly established provisional or revived governments. Some also went astray and began to prey on those for whom they had been fighting so recently. It was no longer a time for lone gunpersons like them. The world has changed, and not in the way they expected.

So they landed near the monastery, which they carefully hid in a nearby canyon. They had picked up this habit during the war with the Horde, though they hadn't expected anyone else to be around, so far from the center of the Known Universe. There were only uninhabited planets around, often ravaged by the Horde. But it was their caution bordering on paranoia that made them survive all those years of guerrilla warfare. The planet was strange, as if at one point it wanted to accept life, but then changed its mind and only mosses and lichens grew here. She had heard that the First Ones could transform entire planets, making them livable. She knew little about this ancient race, on Icarus, especially on the main continent from which their planet was named, there was little interest in the remote past. However, the power of the ancient civilization must have been unimaginable if they were capable of such undertakings. She had heard from friends on Etheri that the First Ones had done terrible things, but Adora, She-Ra herself, was one of them, they couldn't be all that bad.

She has never been to a monastery. On Icarus, this type of practice was abandoned long ago, its inhabitants preferred to look to the future, they reveled in the development of technology. The case with Dedalus was somewhat different. The smaller continent of their planet was much more backward economically, and its inhabitants held much more firmly to tradition and old faith. And it was they who put up the fiercest resistance to the Horde. And they paid a terrible price for it. Three-quarters of the population was killed and most cities were razed to the ground. However, now that their magic had been unleashed, many of them had gained power and were happy to use it to fight the remaining followers of Horde Prime. Only reverent respect for She-ra spared the clones. Their mother was from Dedalus, though with the exception of Jewelstar, they hardly remembered her. This

monastery seemed to be a place where some Serenia-like entity was worshiped on Eridani, a place they both hated immensely.

The monastery was empty, which they expected, but they hoped for a different result. This did not bode well for the places Horde Prime visited. He especially hated places of worship, he was a merciful but jealous master. Although, looking at the level of his madness... So they left the monastery and entered the underground through the sewers, hoping that in this way they would avoid any traps the Horde had left here, because its former ruler was fond of leaving traps for those who wanted to delve too much into his secrets. It was dark here, and the tunnels stretched under the entire complex, creating a veritable maze. They scrambled through it all day and couldn't find it. At first they thought that the inhabitants built a mine here, but then they found strange symbols on the walls, only after closer inspection they concluded that they were the same symbols that were on Adora's sword, that is, they ended up in some ancient structure built by her ancestors where the monastery was built. They did not even find a trace of the inhabitants of the monastery.

They were close to the surface when there was a tremor. They had seen traces of the Other's presence before, but couldn't tell how old they were, so they could hope they were gone. But now they were sure that they were not alone in this eerie place. They were about to eat their meal, but they interrupted it when they heard, or rather felt, a noise. They moved forward, unsure and afraid. They hadn't felt this uneasy since Prime's fall. They really were too old for all this.

They were in front of a room that, judging by the smell of decaying plants, was a hydroponic farm. It was warm here, the entire monastery had power, but they hadn't hit the reactor yet.

„Apparently the gardens did not collapse, how many people do you think lived here?” she asked, staring at the door. There were no locks, no armory or anything like that. Simple people living simple lives that were interrupted by a wicked tyrant.

„Let's get out of here, maybe we won't find anything here. You're right, don't risk” Jewelstar finally said.

She nodded, and they were about to leave when she felt a strange tap on her back.

„I don't like that owl.” behind her back someone said in strangely dull voice.

And then she heard a massive creature running towards them...

After the statue collapsed, her crew members and passengers searched the monastery, or rather its upper part. They found some more evidence that the structure had recently been visited by several other people. Trampled grass, worn dust, fingerprint on the computer. Bina became seriously worried. The place was absolutely eerie, and her experience told her it would only get worse from there. she sighed. They were under a fountain, eating protein bars. Bina looked around and approached Dilayla.

"Maybe it wasn't the best idea to take down that statue." she said looking at the mercenary who shrugged her shoulders.

„Someone had to do it. You know, after all these years, I saw his face for the first time? It's so strange. A dude thirty years ago ruined my life, took everything from me and made me into this.” She clenched her cybernetic fist and smiled grimly and added. "That's all I could do. I don't know if you understand what it's like to want revenge on someone who ruined your life.”

Bina smiled sourly and saw from the corner of her eye that Miss Daisy was surreptitiously listening to them, as was Wrongdak, but he was listening much less secretly.

„You would be surprised. But we killed the one who made us.”

The mercenary looked at her curiously.

„We?” she asked, raising a light blue eyebrow.

„Me and my sister, K-Nacia. One of many. We used to be called the Thousand Daughters, but now we are the Thousand Sisters she said, and seeing Dilayla's confused look she added. “I am a female clone of our Father Jantar. As she said this, she saw Miss Daisy nod as if confirming something she had long suspected, and Wrongdak came up to her in amazement.

"So... are you a clone too?" Just like me… like us?” he asked in an astonished voice. Bina smiled sadly.

„Not quite. Our Father, Jantar, wasn't as crazy as Horde Prime and was… More calculating. The Thousand Daughters was the gang that shook the entire Atrax underworld. But we all owed unconditional obedience to our Father. He put it all together very cleverly. Each of us was different, unique, a separate work of art. In terms of predispositions, he divided them into "Nations", series that were to play different roles in the organization. The A-Nations were thieves and burglars. W-Nations were cybernetic warriors. M-Nations were psykers, and we B-Nations were frauds. Con artists who could sell sand on Akiton. I am B-Natia number 7479... We didn't even get names... But he gave us a lot of freedom because he had a hold on us. You see, we were all created with a defect. We were slowly dying of a neurodegenerative disease and only Jantar had a medicine that could save us, or maybe just slow down the progress of the disease? We started dying at the age of two and lived up to seven years. The older we got, the more and stronger the doses, and our Father sent us on more and more dangerous missions, and sometimes ordered others to kill us.”

„And Ka-Nation?” Dilaya asked. For a moment, Bina thought the mercenary had pronounced the name of this group of her sisters strangely, but she ignored it.

„K-Nation… The whole group was unstable. They were murderers and Assassins, but that K-Natia was extremely fucked up, even more so than our Father. She was as fucked up as your Big

Brother, but that's probably the only way she was able to defy our creator. She tried to kill me before but changed her mind thanks to Igzar

"Did you know Igzar, leader of the Shadows of Tarak?" asked the mercenary appreciatively.

„Yeah, old crazy tomcat. I have to admit it was a bit of a bastard. But it was thanks to him that we managed to take down Jantar. I wasn't interested in power, so my sister, Lady Ka, took over, and that's when it all started. She freaked the hell out, named herself Supreme Queen Ka, and became a tyrant."

"But i belive, like our mister Wrongdak's brother, she suffered a terrible but absolutely deserved fate?" Miss Daisy asked. Bina nodded thoughtfully.

"Yeap, she got into Igzar's black book, and it's something very stupid." Well, she's as dead as a mortal can be now. – replied the dark sorceress.

„Yes, that certainly solved your problem." Miss Daisy said in a voice that the captain sensed a grain of irony."

Rosie was feeling better now. Miss. Daisy was good to her. She knew there was something dark inside her, but she showed her support despite what she had done to Lady Cala. She did not understand her words, or rather did not want to understand them. She wasn't sure what was going on with her, only that she felt confused. Sad and happy at the same time. Her heart was beating like never before. She didn't want to say anything just yet. She just had to deal with their mission for now, and it was terrible.

The upper, above-ground part of the monastery was beautiful. The sun was shining, flowers were blooming, even the water in the fountain was splashing, only birds chirping merrily. It was nice, like a picnic, though she'd never been to one, so she couldn't be sure. But then she saw this statue of this Horde Prime. He had

the face of a Wrongdak, plus a few eyes, but there was something indescribably wicked about that face. She had the impression that she could feel the evil flowing out of him and ... Something she did not understand. A feeling of disappointment, contempt for someone who... wasn't worthy of the power entrusted to him. Then Dilayla destroyed the statue and she felt a little better. But she still felt uneasy, as if something dark hung between them. She knew what was going on, it was a sentence that everyone was afraid to say...

All the inhabitants of the monastery are dead.

They wanted to... But they couldn't turn back, because someone had to find out what happened here. Of course Captain Moonshadow didn't care. Her pirates wanted only riches. She was afraid of this woman, so when she approached her, she jumped. Dilayla immediately approached them.

„Hello, you're Rosie, aren't you?” she asked, but Dilayla cut her off.

„What do you want from her?” asked the mercenary sharply. Everyone fell silent. Eti drew her rifle, Itel summoned the blade. The others also assumed fighting stances. The other subordinates of the pirate did the same, although only this terrifying, only this terrifyingly cute Skittermander showed enthusiasm. Miss Daisy and Lady Cala were the only ones who stayed calm, they were so strong and brave. Rosie put a hand on Dilayla's armored shoulder.

„Everything's all right.” she said, and after thinking about it, the mercenary relaxed. just like the others. "What can I help you with?" she asked, trying to look more confident than she felt.

"You just remind me of my daughter." Moonshadow said sadly. It wasn't the answer she expected at all. So did the others who watched the winged woman, even the members of her crew. The exceptions again were Miss Daisy and Lady Cala.

„That... Captain has a daughter?” she asked confused. The Pirate Captain touched her cheek with her fingers.

„I had ... She was brave and strong, always wanted to get her way ...” said the captain shrilly and turned away from her.

- Your daughter, what happened to her? Miss Daisy asked unexpectedly. Moonshadow looked at her sternly.

„What do you think? She was taken from me. Those who have a happy family life do not dabble in my profession. said the pirate in a sharp voice. Bina gave her a sympathetic look, and Miss Daisy looked for a moment as if she wanted to say something, but then Lady Cala put her hand on her shoulder and the pirate walked away.

In the end, it was necessary to get to the underground of the monastery, which stretched over a huge area. Underneath the upper residential buildings was the entrance to the tunnels. Bina divided them into three groups. One is to look for the broadcasting center, the second for the vault (here she pointedly looked at Captain Moonshadow) and the third for the archive. In addition, of course, they had to find the elevators and find out what actually happened to the inhabitants of the monastery. Bina assigned to first group Arkan-tar, Eti. who decided to take Rosie, Dilayla, Lady Cala and Alatar. To the second, Captain Moonshadow, whom she also wanted to accompany. Miss Daisy, Rechiza, Ireanis, Itel and Lilka were supposed to be in the Last one. Doctor Quin and Wrongdak were supposed to be trying to download information from the Spire to their computers. Itel seemed dissatisfied with this division of tasks, but did nothing other than throw hostile and warning glances at Miss Daisy.

Rosie was confused about the fact that she would be hiking with Eti. She liked the feline girl, but this one was from Itel and she didn't want to come between them. As they were getting ready to leave, Dilayla said to Eti, looking at her firmly.

„Just watch out for Rosie, understood? Otherwise you'll be in trouble," she threatened the feline girl, and Eti nodded gravely. At first Rosie felt angry, oh she didn't want to be 'looked after', she didn't need protection, but something in the exchange of glances between her companions made her want to keep quiet. Eti motioned for her to follow her.

Rosie reluctantly took off her gloves because they allowed them to communicate, but left her glasses on because they had night vision devices built in. Here underground it was, though there were hyper-durable light bulbs here and there that still shone after all these years. Turns and tributaries passed, and Eti reported from time to time that the area was clear. Suddenly the feline girl stopped and signed for Rosie.

„I heard something. Someone is talking there."

It took the intern a few seconds to realize what had happened.

„You speak, I mean you speak in sign language!" she said in amazement.

„It looks." replied the scout.

„But since when?" asked the white-haired girl.

„From now on, or always. Sometimes I'm like that... Let's not talk, I have an important thing to do. „You know, ambush and stuff. she said and turned to Dilayla.

„Some dudes are ahead of us, I'm going to check." She left without waiting for anyone.

As they peeked around the corner, she would see three people, human-like humanoids with colored hair, probably some kind of human. They were armed but didn't look particularly dangerous, at least compared to the Moonshadow pirates or even Eti and her friends.

"They don't look like Wormdak's brothers, but they have a very suspicious owl." the feline reported and activated the cloaking field and, ignoring Dilayla's curses, approached the woman who, like the mercenary, had cybernetic prosthetic limbs and said.

„I don't like that owl.”

And then Dilayla went on the attack.

Tallstar turned instinctively to see a figure in heavy hooded robes wearing a mask and goggles. Instead of a right arm, she had a strange metal prosthesis, but she was armed with a pistol and carried a rifle on her back.

„Take care of the big one.” Tallstar said, and tried to knock the creature down with her cybernetic prosthesis, but she jumped away from it and stabbed it with the blade attached to the wrist of her left hand. The blow slid down her armor, but then she delivered a swift blow to her lower abdomen, which she felt painfully. Then, even worse, she saw another attacker, a white-haired girl with shining hands.

„Jewelstar, i have got two here! she called to her brother” who answered.

„Ours is enough for two.”

Out of the corner of her eye, she saw a huge figure in power armor. She cursed, the situation was becoming really unpleasant. The white-haired girl began to hit her with glowing fists, and the masked figure tried to get her from behind. She resisted, but had to retreat. Her brother fired his old Horde blaster, but the second assailant dodged with surprising dexterity for someone in power armor, but Starla drove a nanoblade into the armor.

„Great, Starla!” she cried, but then her siblings had to dodge the stream of flames. A bullet flew over her head, making her feel

freezing cold. The white-haired assailant grabbed her wrist and twisted it with terrifying ease.

„Hey, stop!” shouted the armored figure in a surprisingly pleasant voice. Are you Star siblings, friends of Wrongdak?" she asked.

The person in the mask touched the shoulder of the white-haired girl, and she let go of her hand. Both people started talking to each other in sign language.

Her siblings had lowered their weapons, but they were ready to keep fighting if needed. The armored figure ordered his helmet down and revealed the quite attractive face of a blue-haired woman. There were Saihe who lived on Etheri, but judging by her equipment and accent, she was not from there, though it is unknown what Entrapta may have come up with in the meantime.

Beside him stood a tall man with gray skin, elongated limbs, and dark eyes without whites. He smiled cheekily at them. Next was a large silver-scaled lizard with wings on its back and multiple cybernetic implants. It was reminiscent of pee from ancient legends. Could another myth have come back to life?

„You... are you also rebels who are fighting Horde?” Jewelstar asked, looking at them in surprise.

„No, we are sholars working for Kemanis University. We're exploring the so-called Ravaged Zone. said the man with glasses.

She blinked confused.

„Ravaged Zone? Kemanis University?” she asked, barely understanding what she heard.

„The Ravaged Zone is name of the place where you live.”. said a beautiful blonde woman who came out of the shadows. She had a epee at her side. “Few in the galaxy have heard of Horde Prime.” She bowed politely to them. “I am Lady Cala Grayskull, and I wish to welcome you to the wide universe

Regaining control

Together with Melog, they decided that flying even at such altitudes was much more pleasant than sailing in a boat. Although she had no experience, half of the captains she sailed with were Sea Hawk... To think that she once doubted Scorpia's sailing talent...

Though she had to admit she'd feel a bit more comfortable if Netossa wasn't so eager to demonstrate Silverwing's capabilities to them, and Entrapta refrained from testing the ship's systems.

The Silverwing was a large flying machine with silvery wings that spanned more than twenty meters and was capable of vertical take-off and landing… and breaking the sound barrier. Which Netossa immediately demonstrated to them with joy .

" Look!" she said as the craft passed over the seas and plains of Etheria. Entrapta squealed with delight, she instinctively clutched the armrests of the chair.

"Where did you get it from? You never used it in the war?" she asked warily, looking around the passenger compartment. It was much tighter than the interior of the Taillsting Scorpia's vehicle . Up to six people of normal size could fit in here.

"Because he was unable to fly. After my grandmother organized a raid to slay the Usurper King, the Shadow Weaver damaged him. We dragged ourselves to Brightmoon with difficulty . But the damage was too great, and for the next thirty years it sat gathering dust in an underground hangar. After the war, I bought parts from an off-planet dealer and repaired it. Spinny was skeptical at first, but then she grew to like it." Netossa explained with joy in her voice. "It's the fastest atmospheric craft on all of

Etheria!" cried Princess Armori and laughed merrily. Melog turned slightly blue in concern. Admittedly, Netossa was a great, albeit over-enthusiastic, pilot.

“And what happened to your ship? The ones Scorpia flew to the ball with.” asked the white-haired woman.

She winced. It was her greatest success, but she wasn't proud of it. To this day, Frosta looked at her reproachfully at all events.

“After we hacked the Black Garnet, Taillsting was hit by lightning, and it turned out that his navigation system failed.” She replied looking out the window

“Couldn't you fix it? “asked the surprised princess of Armoria . “You had all of Hordak's facilities .”

"It also fried its friend-or-foe system, and any inorganic flying object without that First Ones-design device was destroyed, probably by Light Hope." Entrapta said. “ I've built many flying machines, even before I worked for you. But they all exploded, absolutely all of them. Silverwing and Taillsting are remade First One vehicles.”

She bristled.

"We're on the First Ones' vehicle now?" she asked scared. He and Melog wagged their tails in sync.

“Yes, judging by the data and technical specifications on Darla, it was a strategic bomber. It was supposed to drop weapons of mass destruction, atomic bombs, for example, on critical targets.”

"Like the bombs those psychos from Bellum dropped on themselves ?" she asked, genuinely scared this time, as if the vehicle was going to explode at any moment. The people of Bellum fight the Horde twenty years ago. When they started losing, they took a desperate step: they dropped nuclear warheads on the entire planet, rendering it uninhabitable. Only a few giant fortresses- shelters built in mountain ranges have

survived. Even Horde Prime must have been impressed by their act, for he refrained from further attacks. The people of Bellum, the Coldhearts , claimed to have won the war, though they had killed their world.

Bellum was an ally of Etheri, but they caused more trouble than they helped. They demanded that Glimmer give them the captured fleet, allocate all available resources to defeat the Horde Ultimate and the Heavenly Brothers, preferably by orbital bombardment ... They could not completely ignore them, however, because they had the most powerful army among their allies. Ambassador John Kilthem lived in Brightmoon and was a pain in the ass of them all.

“Don't be afraid, we don't have such weapons here. Though we are not defenseless either. Netossa said smiling a bit diabolically.” She shrugged and began to rummage through the packages.

"Just don't let Spinny pack us those sandwiches. You see, she's eating herring with toffee and pickles now.” Netossa laughed, smiling tenderly.

“And I ate something like that recently.” she said thoughtfully. Netossa gave her a sidelong look and said a strange Aha.

They flew towards the Kingdom of snow, which took them a while. It was a remote and vast realm, almost as large as Brightmoon , though less populated. It was always cold here, though not as many thought, she'd heard. Apparently, on other planets that had that sun, it was weird, and sometimes in one place it was hot and then cold. Once they went to Eridani prepared to bask in the warmth, only to find that frost and snow greeted them. In addition, there were no clothes anywhere for people of their size. On the way back everyone was sneezing and couching, but it was a successful adventure. Frosta lived in her castle made of crystal and ice , though she usually stayed in the warmer part of the wood and stone castle. They landed on a wide airfield for ships and similar vehicles. It was crowded here, and Silverwing was by far the largest, so Netossa had to work hard to

land properly. Then they went to the palace. She tried to smile friendlyly at the ice guards, but they kept their eyes on her. Well, she's earned a certain reputation.

They wandered the corridors for a long time, she had the impression that they were not very welcome here. Finally, they ended up in front of Frosty's office . From there came a tall Saihe dressed in blue armor resembling an insect. Something about her posture was oddly familiar.

"If you call me Shadow Weaver's ward, I can't vouch for myself." She growled, claws out.

The woman looked at her surprised.

“Ah, it's you... I heard about you. You knew Light Spinner well . “ she stated rather than asked. Her voice was lower and hoarser than the dark sorceress's.

“I knew Shadow Weaver. Light Spinner died many years ago, If you want to talk about her, ask Mikah , though I doubt he will answer” she replied sharply, but she retracted her claws.

“Yes, I heard she hurt you. Well, not only you. And this woman… What does she want from me?” she asked, looking at Entrapta , who began to look at her as if she were a research object

“Shadow Weaver was never studied, but her ability to draw magic from her surroundings was fascinating. By learning the physiology of an object related to it, we can finally decipher one of Etheria's greatest mysteries.” Entrapta explained, continuing her research. Catra felt a little sympathy.

" Entrapta, you will certainly have the opportunity to examine someday lady... " She looked at the woman questioningly.

“Storm Heart. Storm Heart the Guardian Storm. – said the woman – We will meet sooner than you think .

She had a feeling that there would be many unwanted guests at the wedding.

It turned out that Frosta is not in the castle. They were greeted by the Chancellor, a person so sullen and serious that she felt at home. It didn't bode well for this person. When asked where she was, she heard that she left with the Techmaster's Bow's fathers in search of some ruins. Saying this, he looked as if the ice princess had offended him and his parents with this act. She sighed and told her friends as they left.

"I did not expect such difficulties. We'll look for Frosta or you'd rather go back to your families and activities." she asked, looking questioningly at both women. They had their families and important jobs, she had her responsibilities too, but she was probably a kind of leader here. Netossa looked at her surprised.

"Of course we're looking for her. It was my idea after all, I warned Spinny that it might take a while. At most, the next time we go on a similar trip, we will give the kids to the babysitter and go on a trip together, remember the good old days." She smiled with a dreamy expression. But then she became serious. "I don't like that chancellor talking to Storm Heart behind Frosta's back . In the old days, the Isles of Sorrow only traded with Scorpions and the Star Isles, and as far as I know, it's a gloomy place. The inhabitants are said to worship some kind of spideress , just as the townspeople of Eridani worship this Iomdi thing . Netossa shook her head. Yes, it suited Shadow Weaver.

She looked at Entrapta .

"What do you think? she asked her friend, apparently snapping her out of her thoughts on the datapad." She looked at them surprised.

"Yes? I'm sorry, I was just thinking about a secret, mine and Catra's."

She grabbed her forehead.

“Entrapta, I asked you something! she said, trying not to shout at her friend, but Melog growled.

“Don't worry, Adora will be the first to know about everything!” She said and patted her shoulder. Netossa made a strange face and covered her mouth with her hand.

"What do you think about us looking for Frosty ?" she said, massaging her forehead between her eyes.

“I told Hordak that I might be gone for a day or a week, maybe even a month. He's ready for it.” she said, and headed for Silverwing.

She sighed. She hoped Frost hadn't gone far. After all, how fast could she wander in the company of householders like George and Lance”

“Hold on, we're just entering the gravel pit!” she called to George and Lance in the backseat of her landspeeder. The vehicle was built by combining solutions from old Horde skimmers and Prime's combat drones . Three gravity engines gave this triangular machine excellent stability, but also great speed. It was certainly the fastest land vehicle on Etheri.

“Everything's all right.” George groaned, though he looked as if it were the other way around. Lance looked around holding the telescope to his eye and admired the views. When his husband saw it, he snatched the telescope from his hands and hid it in the glove box.

"Be careful, if we brake hard at this speed..." He didn't have to finish the description, because Lance realized what was at stake and turned pale.

“Sorry. I forget myself sometimes. The nature here is so majestic.” he said to his husband. She had to give them a reason. The views in her kingdom were beautiful. Majestic mountains shooting up to the sky. Flowery plains as far as the eye can see. Fancifully shaped rocks were everywhere, reminiscent of creatures from legend such as owlbears or dragons . Why would anyone living in such a beautiful country want to care about politics?!

She was glad of this trip, finally able to break away from the whining of the chancellor and the nagging of the heads of the great clans. Maybe she should take him on this adventure too? He'd be entertained, amused, a little scared, but he'd finally feel alive instead of whining about imperial titles. It will be a great trip, they will explore ruins like Adora, Glimmer and Catra. Ruins…

“Are these the ruins of the First Ones? That crystal and blue? Do you think I'll find another sword there? Or a magic cat? Or the Magic Goat! I like goats! “ she screamed and made a sharp turn. Bowa 's fathers groaned as they were thrown.

“We do not know. It's a very old city. He is mentioned in several stories and one book”. George said, trying to stay straight.

“Stories? But scary ones, about monsters and murderers!” she asked in delight. She liked it more and more.

“Yes, very scary. Supposedly, the city was inhabited by some terrible, wicked beings who built cities with alien architecture. Apparently, a monster with countless mouths and eyes lives there to this day.” Lance said with all seriousness in his voice. She thought for a moment.

“Why didn't anyone count them? Just sit down and count.” she said, and looked at the Bowa fathers questioningly. George scratched his head.

“ This is probably the most important feature of all scary monsters. They are very difficult to describe, especially when they try to devour you.” he said, slightly taken aback by her question.

“Maybe we can count them.” she said, and burst into the most sincere and joyful laugh in months. Yes, it will be a great adventure!

She believed this trip would make a difference. That she would finally be able to get out of this deadlock in her life… Not that she would finally be able to regain control of it. For as long as she could remember, someone else had always tried to bend her to his will. First Hordak and Shadow Weaver, then the dark sorceress was replaced by Catra. And then they had to hide from the real Horde, not the ridiculous imitation they belonged to. She believed that once she led the People's Rebellion, she would finally regain… no, finally gain control of her own life. But she only felt even more lost. Doctor Moors , Mi-Go, Scarlet. Especially Scarlet, they wanted to bend her to their will again. To turn back into a kid whose whole point of existence was to follow orders. She had had enough of it. Kyle and Rogelio might have accepted it, though she didn't understand why. Maybe the Fright Zone took a lot more from them than the others. Or was she the one who resisted its pernicious influence more than others? Only she, as one of the few, retained her own desires, her own ambition.

“You're ambitious too, much more ambitious than we all imagine.” she thought as she looked at Scarlet lying beside her. The woman seemed to be asleep, though she suspected she was only pretending to be asleep. At first she thought it was Kyle or Rogelio sneaking in, but then it turned out to be the red-haired woman. The first time she was with another girl. She used to dream about Scorpia. There was nothing strange about it, half of the cadets had a crush on a strong and nice scorpion princess. And that one chose Catra anyway , who hadn't seen the world but Adora , and in the end she ended up with this stupid flower princess...

Both common sense and loyalty to her boyfriends told her to get that woman out of the tent, but she told herself she was fucking it and… well, she was fucking her too. Scarlett was good at it, you had to give her that. In the old days, she paid no attention to her

at all. It wasn't until after the war that she met the real Scarlet and was confused. She didn't think that the red-haired girl could hide so much. She was always just a lazy cadet who was only interested in getting out of class and then getting the most boring job that no one else would take anyway. She usually disappeared into the darkness of the Zone's corridors then. Everyone knew it, but in those days, no one cared. Everyone had more important things to do. Also, no one expected Adora to find that cursed sword and started to transform into a blonde warrior, why shouldn't Scarlet become a sorceress. her sorceress. Her right hand. Her…

My own Shadow Weaver. she thought, and felt bad. She needed some air, so she dressed and left the tent.

Cold greeted her. Kyle and Rogelio slept in their tents separately, though after what had happened today, she preferred not to check. They never promised or forbade anything, but she had a constant feeling that she had betrayed them. She looked up at the starry sky and smiled to herself. "They're not as bad as I thought." she thought.

"Looking at the stars is like looking into the eyes of the dead, don't you think?" she heard Dr. Moors ' voice behind her and flinched. She spun around and saw the brain in the cylinder, tilted so it could watch the sky. He was still fucking creepy.

"What do you mean?" she asked, looking at the mad scientist with undisguised disgust.

"The light that reaches us is thousands of years old. Those who saw them for the first time are dead for centuries."

Shivers ran through her, and the moment of delight passed forever. She looked at the glacier stretching out before them. There the dead city waited, with its treasures and riches. Her salvation awaited her there. Opportunity to has finally regained control over her life.

“Do you remember our deal? Or rather, your deal with the Overseer.” said the brain in the cylinder. She smiled contemptuously at him.

“So you know everything.” she said.

"It's always wise to know more than others," replied the Brain in the Cylinder.

“She used to say that too. Shadow Weaver.” she said, and when she saw that Dr. Moors laughed contemptuously. “You're still afraid of her, even though she's been dead for years.”

“Is not dead which can eternal lie, and with strange aeons even death may die. She was a powerful sorcerer and had dealings with dark forces that made Horde Prime mere speck, an intrusive worm .”

She ignored the ghastly doctor. Looking at the mountain range stretching out before her, she finally understood one thing. All her life she's been a pawn, a pawn in the hands of Shadow Weaver, Hordak , Catra. The ones who always used her and her friends in their games. Games whose rules they didn't even fully understand, they only thought they were players, and they were like these blind mice. They forced them all to do terrible things for a cause that made no sense. Now, however, he will only fight for himself. She regain control of her life, and anyone who opposes her will die like rat.

They saw Frosta three hours after leaving her castle. Not because the girl happened to be so far from her castle, but she was not easy to find in this wasteland. They stopped in front of her vehicle, and as they left, the girl ran to them and jumped to hug Netossa, while Entrapta began examining her landspeeder, barely registering the existence of Georg and Lance.

“ Glad you're here. Dad Glimmer asked Uncles George and Lance to find an ancient city with monsters. are you going there too?”

"Actually, he just asked us to know something about him." Lance said carefully. She groaned as Entrapta priking her hair.

“Ruins? First Ones! Catra, you know, I'm just thinking, it wouldn't hurt if, by the way, we” she started, but Lance cut her off.

“Not the First Ones, actually. They were of another ancient race, equally ancient and mysterious.”

She groaned. She couldn't say that the first ones were mysterious to her, after all, she knew one of them ... deeply. But she didn't like exploring more cursed ruins. She looked at Melog eating Frosta's dried anchovies. When he noticed that she was staring at him, he pulled away from the girl in embarrassment. Not everything that came out of the ruins was bad... Maybe they'd find something valuable there... Or they wouldn't let something dangerous fall into the wrong hands.

"We just came for a certain item that Netossa's grandmother gave your mother." But we can accompany you if Mikach sees fit to investigate.

“This item is in the vault, when we get back, I'll give it to you. So where are we going?” asked the ice princess.

Entrapta didn't have to be persuaded, she was already the heart of the excavations, looking for damn ancient devices. All that was left was to hope that it wouldn't be another doomsday machine. But she looked at Netossa, she might not be too happy about taking her away from her family. However, Princess Armori was already carrying some sort of tricycle with a small trailer in the back.

“I knew I'd need him. We'll leave the Silverwing here, closer to the mountains, and there'll be nowhere to land anyway, and no one but me knows how to fly it anyway.” Netossa said.

She smiled widely hearing her words. Maybe that was a really good idea. She will also need an adventure during which she will be able to take a break from it all, from the truth about herself.

Maybe it would help her regain control of her life, because she felt like she was slowly losing it.

Shadow of the Past - Arelarti

She woke up.

Here in the middle of the Swamp, the humidity was so pervasive that she could hardly feel it. The cold didn't bother her either, though the other members of the expedition were of a slightly different opinion. A few started coughing, a some even had symptoms of swamp fever. They traveled for a week. At first they traveled through the outer marshes. This was an area once inhabited by the people of Carurystal, but has now been swallowed up by the cursed Kranor Rill. The process was slow but steady. First, the flora changed. Old well-known plants were being replaced by those found in these a hundred times cursed swamps. They broke down the soil into a muddy substance that bound the salt and water into a toxic substance that nothing else could grow on, nothing that was not native to this awful place. Then came the animals of Kranor Rill. Almost everything that lived here was poisonous or carried some kind of parasite that caused deadly diseases. They led to the extinction of the local fauna and flora, and this often led to the exodus of the former inhabitants. And finally the Riliti came and kill all that was left. That's what the elf Krianese told her, but she didn't trust her. She didn't feel like a representative of this race, the word "elf" wasn't even known on Etheri, only Saihe , and most of them didn't even know their native language. It was different, of course, in her native isles of sorrow, where many ancient traditions were cultivated, but most of them were as foreign, if not more so, to the Elves as to the Saihe . After all, she had renounced her homeland so long ago, choosing the cosmopolitan Mystacor.

But it was also about something completely different. Krianese was a priestess of Elorithu , and she abhorred priests with all her heart, she almost became one herself at end. On Etheri, the

inhabitants were not guided by the commands of the gods or darker beings, they shaped their own destiny. "Except fools like me," she laughed, stretching her back. She stood on a causeway made of black stone veined with green, from which almost all the native structures they encountered in the marshes were made. At least in their inner part.

At the beginning, when they traveled through the areas recently abandoned by the inhabitants, they came across the ruins of buildings and villages slowly sinking into the sodden ground. Most of them were in surprisingly good condition. The third night they spent in the mansion, abandoned many years ago but still habitable. The Riliti had not robbed him or vented their fury on him as the soldiers under her command had done. Even the Galactic Horde, with Horde Prime's penchant for keeping infrastructure intact, the damage was much greater. There was even furniture and electronics left, one brass laptop even worked when hooked up to a portable generator, but there were only pictures of horses and flower beds and some family pictures and stuff like that, nothing of value. One of Vanesa's Norington guards took it, hoping that he could later sell it to relatives of the owners of the mansion. Perhaps someone will want to recover family heirlooms. Most of the expedition members were glad to be able to rest indoors, but she felt uneasy, which was fully justified if you were a person of her experience. Both Sir Rakima and Asindesa shared her concerns, Krianese was rather all the same. The elf looked like the one who would make friends with a certain purple-haired girl. The three of them went outside and stood in a garden covered with the strange vegetation of Kranor Rill.

“I do not like it.” she told her companions.

“What? This palace, this swamp or this expedition?” asked Sir Rakima . He had dark green scales and a scar on his collarbone.

“You asked a very good question” she thought after listening to the reptile.

“I know how armies that plunder conquered areas work.” she said carefully, wondering if she had said too much. “Never have buildings been left so intact. Here, the invaders were not interested in looting or even conquest, only… getting rid of the inhabitants.”Asindesa adjusted her beautiful golden hair thoughtfully. It's amazing that even under these conditions she was able to take care of them.

“The swarm does the same. Its components were completely uninterested in looting occupied territories. There were diversionary actions, or to cause terror among the civilian population of the attacked planets, but mainly he tried to flood us with living mass. Sometimes in the hinterland you could find almost undamaged towns. Sometimes there were survivors in them. It was not profitable for the components to pursue individual people. After the resistance was crushed, all the biomass was decomposed by microbes anyway, or devoured by swarms of the consumers. They left behind only a shell of the world from which he could extract minerals and geothermal energy for centuries, but even there, survivors can be found hiding among the rubble of their world. This similarity is puzzling.” said the beautiful knight.

She thought for a moment, as she wasn't sure how much she could reveal, but decided that since her informant was so willing to share information, it couldn't be a big secret. And even if they were, Kane Adamson, may be he was the Archduke of Carurystal, but what could any mortal do against Chaos Creeping.

"According to my information, the Riliti are bioroids spawned from a powerful ancient race called Krellans ." These beings created some magitech computers that enslaved them.” She shuddered as she always did when she thought about it.

“They're living robots.” Vesk said and nodded. “With Iomadae's help, we will defeat them.” he said with all seriousness. She had to suppress a snort, for she knew well that the will of higher beings seldom considered the desires of mortals.

The next day they reached the marshes proper, and that was where her lack of field command knowledge came in. The marshes proved impassable to their mechanical horses. They almost had their journey end prematurely. Fortunately , Krianese discovered a causeway that crossed the Kranor Rill. It was made of this strange black green-veined stone. The road was wide and they could pass it easily, but Sir Rakima rightly pointed out that they would be vulnerable to an ambush attack. But they had no other choice, because she had no intention of returning empty-handed. So they set out for the heart of the accursed swamp.

The ride was relatively easy, but quite slow because of the amount of supplies they had to drag behind them. It should also not be forgotten that most of the participants had no idea about the military, or even about traveling further than to camp in the forest, and many with war experience were elderly. Perhaps only the lack of awareness of the seriousness of the situation was the reason for enthusiasm felt by most of the expedition members. In fact, she felt it too. While serving Hordak , she was never emotionally involved in the conflict, for her service was only a means to an end. This time, despite knowing the hopelessness of the whole enterprise, she wanted to be a part of it. The reason for her unusual behavior was very simple, but at the same time she felt like never before. She felt happy and terrified at the same time.

Call it, old stupid woman. She thought on the seventh day of the expedition and the first day of traveling on the causeway. Despite the cold and all-pervasive moisture, she felt a pleasant warmth spread over her twisted body. Asindesa di Vir stood at the edge of the dike, her golden red hair blowing in the wind. But then she saw the elf Krianese standing beside her , and felt her clawed hands clench in anger. She suppressed her anger, not… jealousy, and approached the women. Asindesa gave her a warm, welcoming smile.

"Our folower of Eloritu has news for you that might interest you."

She raised an eyebrow, skeptical of what great news a scientist priestess might have. Krianese had short dark blue hair and a solemn, focused face. *At least she doesn't smile at everyone like an idiot*

“The flora here is of foreign origin. It is difficult to confirm this without more detailed research, but the study of morphology itself seems to confirm this thesis. A simple genetic scan too, although access to a broader database would be useful to trace the evolutionary processes to which they were subjected.” she said in an absolutely matter-of-fact, though devoid of emotion voice. It's true, she was genuinely intrigued. She looked at the Lady of Blades appreciatively, and which bared her teeth in a smile.

“That's interesting... I can help a bit... collect specimens for research. For most of my life I've dealt with plants... I had... I have a wonderful garden”. she said thoughtfully, feeling grateful to the Hellknight.

“That's great, in your free time, will you help me collect samples and plant fragments for future research? This could be a great discovery, shedding a whole new light on the natural history of these swamps and the History of Carurystal in general” said the elf with curiosity

Be careful, digging into the past never ends well for the curious she thought grimly, but against common sense she said.

“Yes, I'll be happy to help you.”

All morning, while the others ate leisurely breakfast, she, Asindesa , and Krianes gathered plants. For a short time, she finally felt happy, despite the endless, cursed swamps of Kranor Rill surrounding her…

The first attack took place on the second day after reaching the swamp. The causeway was intersected at regular intervals by another, running perpendicularly. It formed a crossroads around

which rose several buildings made of the same black veined stone as the road. They were unfinished or possibly destroyed. She couldn't tell for sure. When they reached the second intersection, the Riliti appeared. They didn't notice them until it was too late. Suddenly, two huge creatures sprang out of the muddy water, and two others launched strange, spike-like spears . A green Lightning bolt flew towards them from between the buildings . She struck down the first of the monsters with a magical black-colored bolt, saving the life of a young nobleman, but the second creature sliced Vanessa Norington in half until its broad golden sword got stuck in her steed. The aristocrat's guard, the same one who had taken the laptop earlier, tried to take the opportunity that Riliti's sword was trapped and tried to shoot him, but the monster spat its long tongue from its mouth and snatched the gun from him, then lunged at him with its claws. He killed two more members of the expedition before Sir Rakima knocked him down with his hammer. The beasts were huge, even bigger than Vesks and Troxes . They had powerful claws and mouths with a wide sharp plate capable of severing a limb, and it was covered with thick scales capable of stopping a bullet. The creature hiding between the buildings was taller and thinner, wearing a belt with tools of unknown purpose. He had a strange staff of golden metal in his paws that shot green lightning bolts. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw that Asindesa had knocked down one of the monsters and the other had been shot by the expedition members. Two members of the expedition, however, lay dead despite superficial wounds, their lips were blackened, indicating the use of poison. She herself began to weave the spell and summoned shadowy tentacles that tore apart the monster firing from between the buildings. However, he managed to shoot two more guards. They were lying on a stone. and smoke billowed from their twisted bodies. They had lost eight expedition members in total, a fair trade for five Riliti, according to her experience as a Horde commander. The other members of the expedition, however, did not see it that way. Things have clearly deteriorated. *Well, no one said it was going to be a picnic*

Krianese died in a rather ridiculous way. Every morning and evening the three of them, together with Asindesa and the Elven priestess, scoured the area near the causeway and collected plants, Krianes and Asindesa collected plants, and she photographed them with her simple datapad for retirees. She had been so happy then, though she knew how ridiculous it was in her situation. It wasn't anything romantic, they were just picking flowers... Were Adora and Catra picking flowers too? Did they dance at the balls among dozens of happy people? She had no idea, but over the past five years she'd come to realize that she really knew so little. That day she was taking a picture of a small plant and strangely metallic leaves that were so sharp they could cut to the bone. Some of the expedition members looked down on the whole situation, they didn't like the not-so-romance, but she didn't care, she never cared about what other people thought. She was the Shadow Weaver, after all, the most hated person on Etheria. Maybe after you , *Hordak , though at least that annoying girl Entrapta liked you .*

"What are you going to do?" The Lady of Blades asked, looking at her. For a moment her heart beat faster, but the hell knight added." On a mission." said Asindesa, blushing.

It's unsettling, but she wasn't sure what she was going to do. She just wanted to be with Asindesa .

"I want to find Arelarti, a city in the middle of these swamps, and take pictures of it, because apparently even satellites can't see them. I think that if people in our position talk about what's going on here, maybe... Someone will take care of it all." she said, trying to sound credible, although she knew very well that she was lying to the living eyes of a woman she had a deep feeling for. But Asindesa only nodded… Then she heard Krianese calling them.

"Look at these plants. I think there are some eggs here, probably roe or spawn. "The elf exclaimed, pointing to a strange round cluster of plants indeed covered with some kind of eggs, but suddenly a creature resembling Riliti in the same way a monkey resembled a human. emerged from the mud. Before anyone could

react, the beast seized the leg of the elven scholar with sharp fangs, although it was not she who killed Krianese, but the fire of their guards, who in fear did not pay attention to the fact that they hit the woman and the monster equally. Asindesa ordered a cease fire, and she hurled a shadow bolt and the creature died. However, it was too late for Krianese . Her body lay half-submerged in mud with multiple gunshot wounds. *So it is end of Romantic flower picking*

The journey now proceeded in gloomy moods. Half of their expedition members turned back. From what she later learned, most of them made it back to their homes unscathed, so she guess it wasn't a bad decision. But among those who remained there was a strange grim determination worthy of the lost. She sensed it in Adora too, that last day when she had done that one good thing…. Though she didn't sense that grim determination in Asindesa and Sir Rakima . Faith in the code of hell knights or the protective grace of the goddess gave them strength. In fact, it was the same with her. Her dark patron gave her strength as well, though in a much more literal way.

And he will protect me from death, unlike the gods worshiped by mortals, because he has great plans for me, she thought and felt a grip of horror in her heart, because she understood that it was to escape from the imperious grip of Creeping Chaos was that she has wanted. She was looking loophole in their contract. But she would not outsmart the Great Outer God, why she imagine something such absurd. She looked at the Lady of Blades riding beside her and realized with horror that her arrogance had put her to death. She barely managed to control her panic attack. She was a Shadow Weaver after all, the wickedest of the wicked, she had strength and she would have to use it all if she wanted to save the Lady of Blades.

Hell began when they saw the walls of the cursed Arelarti in the distance. They found themselves in the middle of another intersection. In each successive intersection, the buildings were better and better made and more numerous. It was the size of a small village. Some of the buildings looked like warehouses, Others looked like generators, and others were intended for an unknown purpose. She saw a tall watchtower and decided to climb it to take a look around. At the top he saw that a transverse causeway joined another that ran towards the city. She realized that they all formed a spider-like web together. She understood that the whole swamp contained one huge structure, the purpose of which was unknown, and certainly ominous. Only once had she heard such an intricate and complex work. It was the Heart of Etheria, a creation that disgusted even Crawling Chaos. Arelarti was the center…the heart of it all. It was there that the ancient techno evil slumbered. But was it her business? The galaxy turned out to be a place full of inexpressibly terrible secrets that she had no desire to explore. What she experienced would shatter the minds of weaker beings. When she was immersed in these sad thoughts, she heard the scream of the same nobleman whom she had saved a few days ago.

"Riliti! They hide here …" There was a flash of green light, and there was a scream. Well, the rescue turned out to be remarkably temporary. The air quivered as the cloaking field fell, and all three types of Riliti they had encountered were suddenly swarming everywhere. There was a fourth variety, even more muscular and clad in massive black stone armor whose veins pulsed with green energy. They carried long Khopesh -like swords and dartguns of poison-coated steel darts. Their advance was unstoppable, the surprised expedition members unable to put up a coordinated resistance. She threw a ball of black fire that consumed many monsters. Then, using the old levitation spell she liked to use in the Fright Zone, she jumped out of the watchtower and fell down, landing next to Asindesa and Sir Rakim . After a while, only the three of them stayed on their feet.

"It was an honor to fight with you." The priest of Iomadae shouted, smashing the skull of the beast Riliti.

"It will also be an honor to die by your side." added the Lady of Blades

She rolled her eyes.

“The greatest honor will be to remember this adventure by the fireplace. Try to protect me and with a bit of luck I'll be able to take them all down, you just have to cover me before I gather enough power! She screamed and began to absorb the power. Meanwhile, Sir Rakima and Asindesa di Vir struck blow after blow, knocking down more opponents. They were all splattered with the crimson blood of the monsters. She drew more and more power, but it was still too little, too slow. Suddenly , Asindesa was hit by a poisoned dart in the frame. Although the dart flew through, the woman began to stagger on her feet. So she made a desperate decision to save the woman who was so important to her. She took of the obsidian necklace and was flooded with power from Nyarlathotep himself . Even the holographic mask showed her true form now, but that didn't matter now. At one point, all the Riliti suddenly fell to their knees, and a tall figure in hooded robes emerged from among them. She had her hand outstretched upwards, on which she wore a ring with red stone covered with green veins. Then she gathered all her power and from all shadowed places dark shadowy blades slashed at the attackers, but avoided her allies. Sir Rakima looked at her with appreciation and gratitude, but she returned him with an apologetic smile, grabbed the Lady of Blades by the hand and fled with her through the void, leaving the priest to die.

They teleported to Grayskull's main dinner hall . She yelled at the crowded servants, who stared with wide opened eyes like idiots, to run for Dr. Rephan as soon as possible, and then she cast all possible spells that could slow or stop the effects of the poison. Soon the infernal knight was taken to the infirmary. She oversaw the treatment of her dearest friend for the next ten hours, then followed Dr. Rephan to her office.

"You did your best, now no one will be able to accuse us of anything when the Lady of Blades dies, which will probably happen soon" said the doctor-cultist. She looked at him, and there was death itself in her eyes.

“Cannot fall hair from the head of Asindesa di Vir.” she said with undisguised threat in her voice. Rephan shook his head sharply.

“I can't agree to that. If the hellknight becomes suspicious, then ...” He didn't finish because she put her hand to his chest and blew up his heart with the rest of her power. *I like to demonstrate my new tricks*

Wandering through dark corridors...

Tallstar blinked twice. This woman used a name that sounded like Shera's battle cry . Plus, she looked so much like Adora… No, like She- Ra … She was tall and strong and beautiful, she could almost see the young woman radiating an inner glow. In fact, Starla was almost glowing of awe, and her brother was pretty close too. She herself had the biggest shock since learning about the death of this Horde Prime

“So it's true. Horde Prime was not the ruler of the entire known universe!” She gasped, not hiding her surprise. The individual who wore glasses and had a strange implant in his head smiled indulgently, arousing her reluctance, and said.

“That would be difficult considering the scale of the universe. There are tens of thousands of empires and millions of civilizations in it. Even the oldest dragons and liches knew only a handful of its secrets.” His tone was matter-of-fact, if a little condescending.

“Dragons? Like him?” Starla pointed to the silver reptile, but he interrupted the discussion.

“My name is Alatar and I'm not a dragon, but a dragonkin. Typical dragons are much bigger... and it's not true that dragonkin riders exist.” he said firmly, and the masked girl added, wagging her tail to the rhythm of the words.

“There are debates among scholars as to whether Alatar is a small dragon or a plump Dragonkin.”

Lady Cala laughed softly.

“Our friend Eti has a very specific sense of humor.” said the aristocrat

“I have no sense of humor. And to you, I am Mrs. Eterna. And don't listen to Stinka, she is a person of universal hatred and contempt throughout the galaxy. Eti or Eterna interjected in a strangely dull voice. The blue-haired woman in the armor gave a short, jerky laugh.” Tallstar had the strange feeling that the sense of the joke was escaping her. She coughed and asked.

“What are you here for? What are you looking for here?”

The blue-haired woman smiled at her, it was a lovely smile, and said.

“My name is Dilayla. Our captain received the distress call and decided to help. I agree with her decision, as do Lady Cala, who seems to be the leader of this research expedition. Now we want to find out what's lurking in the place where the Dawn Flower was worshiped…” she said until Arkan-tar cut in.

“Judging from the carvings on the door, some aspect of the Inheritor was also worshiped here.”

We should take a look at this door though she thought, then asked.

“Dawn Flower? Inheritor?”

“The Dawn Flower is Serenae, and the heiress is Iomadae. You know, the sword, the luminous hair, it glows.” Dilayla explained, touching the golden symbol on her neck representing a golden sword surrounded by rays of light. Starla took a deep breath and asked in delight.

“Do you also have your own She- Ra ?!”

They all looked at her confused, but Jewelstar interjected.

"It seems to be someone similar to the Iomdi who are worshiped on Eridani. I didn't know it was known elsewhere.” There was undisguised resentment in his voice. The aristocrats of Eridani were especially bad for him.

“Iomadae, like Serenae, is worshiped in many places, as are many other gods. Triune, Eloritu , Shelyn, Besmara , Nyarlathotep.” the learned-looking individual was saying, but Lady Cala interrupted him.

“Let's put the religious discussions aside. I'm sorry if this sounds bad, but could you please introduce yourself and explain why you're here?”

“We're freedom fighters. Previously we fought Horde Prime , and now we fight his successors. My name is Jewelstar and these are my sisters Tallstar and Starla. “ They nodded when they brother pointed to them.” We're here for the same reason as you. he explained.

The members of that bizarre expedition also introduced themselves, although the white-haired girl did it through the masked one.

"That means we're probably the first people from our part of the galaxy you've met..." her brother said and felt a bit embarrassed, then suddenly remembered something. “Not counting Wrongs Hordaka ... and Emily! what about them? They're doing fine?”

A masked girl named Eti spoke up.

"Wormdak is laze with Doky upstairs, but he's as stupid as ever, and the Dumbot is doing dumb thins on the most gorgeous ship in the galaxy, but I don't know why you’re interested in them." It's a shame to bother with them.

Lady Cala looked at Eti as if she were an unruly child and translated.

“Wrongdak, as he is now called, is upstairs helping Doctor Quin , our technician, break into Horde Prime's spire , and Emily is on the ship to keep an eye on him.”

Jewelstar nodded in understanding, and Starla smiled brightly , but there was one thing that bothered her.

“Why did you come here? To Prime's empire ? If He hasn't reached you, it must be much better here than in the ruins it left behind.”

She had the impression that Arkan-tar and Alatar were a little confused, but Lady Cala smiled proudly and began to speak in a beautiful sonorous voice that captured hearts.

“My family has lived on Carurystal since time immemorial, and our ancestral home is Grayskull Castle. However, we are not from there, for we came to this world from a place called Etheria , and our founder was Mara ... who died defending this planet ... Actually, she was even called She-Ra, princess of power.”

The answers to the questions that had been occupying her mind for some time were slowly taking shape, but she didn't like the shape. C*lones, how ironic. I ruined my life serving one of them. Hordak gave his life, and the lives of thousands of others, just to please his maker. This woman...These women, at least, had enough strength and determination to kill their Father... Is it yours family custom?* she thought , and anxiously realized that it was probably true. *The implications are hard to grasp. Catra... She must have some connection with this Jantar... Did he create her. Did he create them both?* she thought frantically as she wandered these dark and gloomy corridors of the abandoned monastery. Catra was always so strong and fit, almost like Adora. She never sensed any power from her, but she was always her best student. For a time, she even wanted to make Catra her’s right hand and acolyte ... Although contempt and hatred for her almost daughter never allowed her to appreciate the girl. See her true potential. *Did you do that too, Jantar? Didn't you think that your children, beings you so carefully shaped to live in fear of you, would fight for their future? Will they pay you back for all the harm you've done them? For all the pain and humiliation they had to suffer?* she thought about the man who died not long before she gave her life. There was a secret to it. "If you created Catra and Eti, why did you do it?" she asked herself this question over and over

again without finding any sensible answer. Neither Catra nor Eti were like Bina and Lady Ka, who were clones of this mad scientist, even minus the feline features. Eti was a mystery in itself. Evidently, everyone was aware of her unusual origin, but tried to hide it, although in a galaxy full of such diverse races, the cat girl should not arouse any surprise. The pieces of the puzzle were slowly falling into place, but too slowly, she couldn't afford to wait for everything to work itself out. Fortunately, she had her ways of getting information…

She had been in the monastery once in her long life. It was two years ago on Carurystal, when she visited a similar shrine belonging to the followers of Pharasma . It was just a courtesy visit to make sure that the monks living in House Grayskull's land lacked nothing. Even then, however, she did not visit the monastery buildings, such matters never interested her, although, of course, the higher powers were interested in her much more than she would like. The inhabitants of this place must have believed until the very end that their goddess, this Serenae, would save them. But apparently she had other plans. The gods always had other plans, as she had learned on this damned quest.

The sight of the planets ravaged by Horde Prime shocked her more than she would have expected. Adora and her friends took a cursory tour of the Empire during their journey and were horrified by what they found, but she didn't talk to them about it, there was no time for that then. She knew what a horrible monster Horde Prime was, even bigger than other monster she had helped train. She expected what she would see, thanks to the reports provided by Creeping Chaos, but to see is to believe. She finally understood how close Etheria was to become ashes. It was now that she finally realized whose side she was really on. Of course, now she served a being so completely alien and terrifying that most of her planet's inhabitants would not believe in her existence. All she could do now was fight to prevent more tragedies. She could only count on Nyarlathotep to keep his end of the bargain. So she was at the mercy of a powerful and distant being, like those unfortunates in the convent. *How could I feel better than them? There is still much pride in my dark heart.*

“Don't worry, Miss Daisy! Any despicable Bugs who tries to bite you will surely die from the blows of my axe!” Lilka shouted and made a swing over her head, almost cutting Rechiza down . Itel ordered the red-haired girl with a look to be quiet. Walking slightly behind, Ireanis paid no attention.

She didn't like Lady Cala going with the other group, along with Eti and Rosie. Her ward could be extremely cruel. Rosie once had already defeated Cala , and Eti seemed to be as formidable as Catra, but she doubted that even with Dilayla's help, she would be able to face Calamity's true form . She could only hope that her companion would focus on their mission and not be distracted by her weaknesses.

She looked at Lilka and smiled kindly at her, realizing that she had a great opportunity to get information.

“Miss Lilka, how long have you been traveling together like this?” she asked, trying to sound as friendly and innocent as possible.

“It can be five years.” said the redhead, adjusting the ax on her shoulder.

“And how did such a brave orc like you travel with a human woman, two elves, a dragonkin, an intelligent fish and… who exactly is Eti?”

“Eti is a shooter who shoots. It even shoots well. And I… Because you see. Beyond the seven cosmos lived the great and mighty orc Wagar . He was big, brave and strong even for an orc, and every orc is big, brave and strong. And he was very bored until he heard that there is a Swarm in space, they are such big bugs. And when he heard about it, he took a giant leap through the cosmos. Only it was a big and long jump and it made him very tired so when he landed on Kesler then he couldn't take all the Swarm by himself so he joined Igzar such a dire Pahtra who took him to such a camp and... There was this girl and she.. Her family was killed by the Swarm.. She was so small and weak, but you know what Wagar did ? You know!.” suddenly Lilka stopped and turned sharply

towards her and started screaming. "He repair her!" He saw a real orc in her and pulled her out and said. "You are an orc" and it was true! And together they killed thousands of worms, but there were too many and he said that it is now up to me to bear the honor of the Horde and now I do!." A tear ran down the girl's cheek and Lilka sniffled. The story of the redhead, although seemingly absurd, was so sad and tragic that even her stony heart ached. But she had one more question to ask.

"And Eti wasn't with you then?" she asked and the girl shook her head and said.

"No, Igzar brought her to us on Atrax..." she started in a sad voice, and then Itel also turned towards them and jumped at her with the summoned blade.

"Stop asking her, you old hag. Can't you see I'm about to cry because of you?" the elf shrieked, and she resisted the urge to unleash dark magic to punish the Solarian's impertinence , but the girl added. "Why do you want to ruin our lives?"

She felt all the power drain from her. She looked down and mumbled a soft "sorry." Rechiza stopped, bent her head back and started yelling at them at the top of her lungs.

"Could you guys shut the hell up and focus on finding that fucking archive? We are in a monastery cursed by devils and demons, located in the former territory of the most wicked empire, and we are heading towards a place so terrible that the World's Wound seems like a kindergarten... " She didn't finish as Ireanis interrupted her.

"Oh, we're looking for an archive! They should be that way." said the silver-haired sorceress. The Lashunti looked at her silently.

"How do you know. she asked in a grim tone.

"I've been to many Serenae monasteries, and they're all the same... And then I found the blueprints... you know, because while you guys were talking upstairs about these wise things, I

followed the need... and I had to wipe myself, but there's really nothing to worry about, because it's all here!" she tapped her head. The Solarian and the Twister groaned in unison and walked in the direction the sorceress had indicated. She looked at her thoughtfully. Maybe I just found the perfect source of information…and moonshine."

Who the hell is this She-Ra? Dilayla thought as she studied Lady Cali. *If it has anything to do with that bitch, I don't like her anymore.* The three people in the monastery stared at the aristocrat with a mixture of astonishment and delight, as did Wrongdak, though less ostentatiously. Admittedly, they were a bizarre bunch, but they seemed likeable. At first glance, she recognized the victims of war, those whose fortunes forced them to become soldiers. In essence, they resembled Bina 's kids , though there was no bitter hopelessness in them, as if these adults retained more hope and faith in the world than a bunch of kids. She wondered what had happened to them to keep so much… innocence?

"Your ancestor was THIS Mara? Prev She-Ra?" asked Starla, looking at Lady Cala with delight.

Their group looked at the siblings with incomprehension.

"I don't know who She-Ra was, except that she was someone extremely important to the inhabitants of Etheria. But thousands of years have passed since then. I don't know if our family line has been broken in the meantime, and even if it hasn't, it's hard to say that we are related after so many generations that separate us. " The aristocrat smiled as innocently as an absolutely guilty person could.

"She-Ra... She defeated Horde Prime . She annihilated him and saved us all." – Starla said.

“I see.” Arkan-tar said and looked at Lady Cala and moved away from her almost to the other end of the corridor. "Are you talking about this Lady of Chaos?"

Tallstar snorted loudly.

“Do you really believe in this sham?”

Her brother nodded.

“Horde Ultimate is one of Prime's successors, his self-proclaimed prophet She-Ra and the Etherian princesses are his enemies, so it's no wonder he wants to portray them as servants of darkness”. Arkan tar coughed skeptically, but Rosie’s and Alatar's eyes lit up. "It must be this Saihe from message idea , " Jewelstar added

“Saihe ?” Dilayla asked, though she suspected what they meant.

“Well, someone like you.” The man with the cybernetic eye pointed to the mercenary , who smiled and began to explain.

"I am an Elf and only a half-blood, and the one who spoke was a Drow . For this mistake, you can earn a knife in the ribs in many places.”

The siblings stared at them, surprised by this unexpected lesson on interspecies relations in the galaxy.

“Saihe live on Etheri, but there they do not don’t care of someone’s race.” Jewelstar explained .

“Oh, so these are the reverse Azlanti” Alatar muttered under his breath. Starla wanted to ask something, but Eti cut in.

“I'm a simple shooter. I see someone through the scope, press the trigger, the light goes out. We are here looking for some way to get down and find out what happened to the inhabitants of this place. I mean, what a terrible and dark fate befell them.”

Lady Cala nodded and said.

“I agree with Eti.” The shooter looked at the noblewoman as if she had insulted her. “Then we will find time to tell you about the beautiful and dark sides of the Galaxy, but now is not the time for that. We must solve the mystery of the inhabitants of the monastery, if only to satisfy the requirements of the law, not to mention common decency.” her voice was strong, and Dilayla was reluctant to admit that the woman had a talent for leadership.

"I have an idea," Alatar said, staring at the door of the room. from which came the smell of rotting plants. “It's a hydroponic farm, so they must have some kind of fault-tolerant communication system there. I'll study its layout and be able to determine the layout of the rooms and thus locate the elevator shafts.”

Arkan-tar patted Dragonkin on the back as if he were his protégé.

-You are a talented technomancer . - he praised him, and Alatar put his wings on his back.

“, I took it from the comic.” he said, clearly embarrassed.

“Bloody Nerd to.” Eti added.

The elevator shafts were nearby. There were only two, and unfortunately, the terminals were deliberately destroyed. She and Tallstar swung open the elevator doors and swore together, seeing that they were both downstairs, and the brakes looked suspicious.

“Nice gear, where did you get it?” Tallstar looked at her power armor appreciatively .

“Uh, I bought it because it's an investment ... You know, I'm a mercenary” she said, strangely embarrassed. The other maimed woman nodded.

"Perhaps we'll fly beyond Prime's empire in the future , and arm ourselves." You can't rely on looted Horde gear indefinitely. - she

said. Dilayla looked at the others, who were busy examining the control panel. She addressed Tallstar in a hushed voice.

"Don't ask me how I know this, but a real war fleet commanded by Lord Admiral Antares is approaching the Ravaged Zone. I don't know much about him, but he's a mercenary who made his name fighting an enemy as terrible as Horde Prime. In exchange for information and help, he should give you a lot of equipment and maybe he will help you. Just don't mention the crew we're traveling with and watch out for Lady Ka, she's a dangerous woman. Then I'll give you the bearing…" She turned around in amazement, noticing that Lady Cala had opened the elevator door with her own hand and said."I go down this shaft, let the rest go down the other one" she jumped, grabbing the support cable. The Star siblings exchanged significant glances.

"Sparkle Hand, Alatar , follow me." Eti called and started running down the vertical wall of the second shaft, and Alatar jumped next, spreading his wings. Finally, Rosie ran and stood in the elevator door, waved to them, and before Dilayla could catch her, she jumped and began to glide, falling down and glowing. The siblings still didn't look surprised.

"Is this the norm here? Because for me not. Come on, let's look for the stairs, I think I've seen one somewhere."

Calamity landed on her legs bent, though a less worthy creature would have shattered her legs. Well, perfection was the minimum she expected of herself. Her pupils dilated to purple, allowing her to see even in the deepest darkness, and she moved forward. She needed a moment of solitude to think over recent events.

Nothing was going as it should. She did not know the will of Creeping Chaos and doubted that even such a pure and beautiful mind could not comprehend it. But there were too many cases that unsettled her. First, that deaf kid who was fawning over the Shadow Weaver. It wasn't even about she ha defeat her. She

couldn't use all her power without revealing her full splendour. No... The thing is, Rosie defeated her without much effort, and though she didn't admit it to Shadow Weaver, she feared that she wouldn't even defeat the girl in her true form. Who or what Rosie was, neither of them had any idea who the girl was, though the old witch had taken a liking to the girl for some strange reason. But basically, it didn't bother her. That loss was a much needed lesson in humility. There are many more powerful creatures on this quest, including She- Ra herself , so a little sobering might allow her to survive,

But this wicked cat… This girl annoyed her just by being there. She was something related to that villainous Catra , Shadow Weaver confirmed it. She did not know how the great and the wonderful universe could endure the existence of two such lousy creatures. Even the old hag didn't know it, but she had every right to hate the feline ward. Adora had usurped a destiny she didn't deserve, but this clumsy creature had stolen her place, throwing away the mission that was her very sense existence.

On top of that, that vicious bitch showed her no elementary respect. The wild brat was talking to her like any wench, and she, Calamity , had to pretend to be the benevolent Lady Cala all the time , as she most likely fell under the Shadow Weaver/ Nyarlathotep deal . And the kitty had a goddamn alien artifact, as if she deserved something other than righteous, fiery anger.

There were no words in the languages of the elder races to describe the righteous hatred that pulsed through her veins. So when she entered the next room, rich-looking, reminiscent of a vault, and saw a clone dressed in a gold-red uniform, she smiled and said.

“Let’s dance?”

Rosie was secretly very happy that she and Eti were almost alone now, except for Alatar, of course. She liked Dragonkin , he was

nice and interested in cool things like games and comics. And he was also glad that they were going to some enchanted place with the princesses... But Eti wasn't there and fortunately only they knew sign language and could talk alone... together

“You know, I really didn't want to go in there at the time. I didn't know you and Itel... well, you're a couple.” she said as she felt herself blushing. Etilooked at her in surprise.

"But we're not couple I mean, we're just friends and we sleep together sometimes, but only a few times, that's all. Nothing else.” Eti said, staring at her impassively. Rosie felt a pleasant warmth of relief spread through her body and a great weight lifted from her heart. But then Alatar called out.

“Girls, you better look here. Dragonkin peered into the room from the side, his tail stiffening with horror. As they peered inside, Rosie let out a strange gurgling sound that was her moan. The room was a large cinema where the entire community could gather. Now there were rows and rows of dried corpses… children too. Now it dawned on her what evil had happened here. Eti started talking on the communicator.

“Hey Grimmy , how are you doing with necromancy , because we have a whole room full of corpses here, and they seem to be starting to move.”

...we hear the lament of the dead

The clone looked much more dignified than the ones Shadow Weaver had told her about. No, that wasn't the correct term. The word gorgeous would be more suitable, although kitschy would also adequate. His uniform was red-gold and would have gleamed in the sunlight. However, it was quite impractical. He had no chance of hiding anywhere other than a military parade. It was also quite heavy. On the other hand, could he expect enemies in such a place? Well, he met something more terrible than any foe he could imagine, although the bar wasn't set too high for him. He knelt by the great bronze doors, now sealed, and tried to burn them with a plasma cutter and almost succeeded. When he saw her, he put the cutter aside and grabbed the blaster, which guaranteed himself a long and painful death, because purely theoretically, he could set her clothes on fire with the burner, and she didn't want to walk around bare ass, especially in front of this feline monstrosity.

“Who are you? On behalf of the Horde Ultimate, I order you to drop your weapons.” clone shoutet at her.

She gave a pearly laugh, as befitted a noble lady, and bowed courteously.

"You have had the greatest honor of your little life to stand before Lady Cala Grayskull, but that's not my real name. I must introduce myself properly” she said and jumped towards the confused soldier while she drew her blade and slashed him in the face while dodging a blaster shot. She stood behind him, green gore running down the blade of her sword.

“LOOK AT ME! GIVE ME A NAME!” She dodged again and slashed at the back of his neck before he could even fire.

“ I AM CHILD OF THE KEY AND GATE!” she screamed. The clone's wounds were slight but painful. She ducked slightly from another shot and slashed harder this time, severing the tendons in her shoulder.

“OFFSPRING OF THE ONE WHO IS ALWAYS OR EVERYWHERE. She did a dance pirouette and cut a tendon in his knee, causing him to drop to one knee.

“THE SPAWN OF THE ONE WHO TRULY KNOWS AND SEES EVERYTHING!” She stabbed him in the face again, this time down to the bone.

“I AM CALAMITY AND MAY ALL REJOY AND CRY AT THE SOUND OF THIS NAME!” She hit him with the side of her hand in the frame where he held the gun and crushed it. She felt joy, the greatest since the fight with Azlanti. This is what her life would have been like if she hadn't been robbed of her destiny. The clone, whose face was equal parts pain and terror, asked.

“What are you?!”

She smiled tenderly at him and stroked his cheek.

“I am perfection incarnated.” she said tenderly. Now she would have to kill him and burn the corpse, because noble Lady Cala would not be so cruel in fighting an enemy. Or did they burn it right away? She had already started to reach for the burner when there was a message from that nasty cat. She smiled and answered everyone.

"Just found a clone corpse by the vault. They're horribly torn, and his throat was ripped open.” as she spoke, the fingers of her left hand lengthened, taking the form of bone claws.

“Goodbye my dear ...” and with one stroke of her hand tore his throat. Then she saw a shattered transmitter drop from the clone's hand.

“Fuck!” she roared, and all the defenses left by Horde Prime were activated...

Rechiza had the impression that he was the only sane person here. These kids she couldn't blame, they were young and ignorant of the true evil that lurked among the stars. But the rest? Did they understand the evil lurking here? She looked at Miss Daisy, who was walking next to this bumbling elf, probably fawning over her, because she was counting on free alcohol, she had already noticed that the woman had a serious drinking problem. Although, considering how much she was interested in Rosie and the crazy feline, she might have wanted other services from the silver haired girl. But she was pretty sure the grim elf knew much more than she was telling them all. She suspected that she had persuaded Lady Cala to go on this accursed quest for dark and selfish motives. She really wanted to get on that damn Etheria.

In her eyes, this whole Etheria was a Carcosa-like place. A cursed nexus of evil and horror, where only the most despicable creatures existed, weaving their dark schemes and lurking for the souls of such unfortunate fools as they. Even a monstrous and mad tyrant like Horde Prime could not defeat this Lady of Chaos. Life has taught her that you can only overcome evil with evil. She suspected that Miss Daisy was connected to this Lady of Chaos. Maybe she was even her cultist, her faithful disciple, conditioned and trained to be an obedient servant. Worse yet, she seemed to know this deranged pirate, Captain Moonshadow. She despised pirates and bandits, believed that only the most despicable people made a living by attacking others, and that the few fools who portrayed the romanticized image of these professions in the media were equally evil. She had the feeling that the only people she could trust even remotely was Arkan-tar and perhaps Doctor Quin as well . She hoped that together they would warn the Lord Admiral and he would do something about the evil coming from Etheria .

They finally made it to the archives. It was in surprisingly good condition, probably due to the still functioning airflow system. The smell of old yellowed paper permeated the room. Unfortunately, it was also huge, with thousands, probably tens of thousands, of pages of records from the last few hundred years. Most of it was probably worthless, containing ordinary information about the economic life of the monastery. The numerous books on the shelves promised more hope. Apparently, the room also served as a library. Suddenly she saw a piece of blue cloth lying on the floor that looked like a banner or a sash. But that wasn't the most important thing. For it was covered with inscriptions in the language of the First Ones. She immediately ran in that direction. She picked it up and read it aloud.

“Serenia - Friend of Mara, The She- Ra of Etheria . Honorary member of the Grayskull squadron . Priestess of the Dawn Flower.”

The lashunt looked at Miss Daisy in surprise.

"This Mara, wasn't Lady Cala's ancestor , one of the First Ones?" she asked, not caring that she was revealing the private information that Lady Cala had privately given them. After all, what can these kids understand from this.

"Indeed..." began Miss Daisy, but Lilka interrupted her.

"Are you the one who reads Starlings language?" he asked with his eyes wide open.

“What language?” the Witchwarper asked.

“The language of those who built Eti's hand.” said the Solarian , and Lilka took out a slightly crumpled piece of paper from her bag, on which there was a drawing of a star with a smiling face. At the end of the beams, she had metal hands like Eti's.

“This is what Starlings look like” said the red-haired girl. Miss Daisy stood behind Rechiza and when she saw the drawing her eyes widened and she could hardly contain her burst of laughter.

"So this is what you think the First ones look like?" she asked, trying to control herself. It was strange to see the amused dark sorceress.

“So, what are the Starlings supposed to look like?” Lila asked surprised.

Itel glared at her and said.

“No one, not even Dr. Sidonius, one of the galaxy's greatest minds and authority on the Firsones, can read their handwriting. The elf crossed her arms over her chest. Lashunti smiled indulgently.

"It's very interesting, because it was Dr. Sidonius who created the eyes that allow me to read the writing of the First Ones."

The elf looked at her astonished and shocked, but then Eti spoke through the communicator.

Actually, the sight of moving bodies didn't scare Eti. She had seen the living dead before, and more than once. They were even on Eox , albeit briefly. In fact, that the corpses started to move made them a lot less scary than a whole room full of murdered inhabitants. She was prepared for this sight, she was disillusioned after all. But even so, when she saw the entire hall filled with over a hundred bodies, including children, even she was shocked, although she did not show it. But the undead were just a threat, something she could deal with. She was literally made for fighting…and more, which could come in handy too. She notified everyone, especially the Grimmy team , and then told Alatar.

“Grab Sparkle Hand and go!” she cried, seeing that the white-haired girl was staring paralyzed at the place of the murder. Alatar grabbed her arm, even if she was vexing Alatar, she couldn't deny him strength, and then she took an incendiary grenade and threw it into the largest tangle of undead and immediately ran away. She instinctively squeezed her ear canals just before the explosion, but the roar was still deafening. She ran ahead, knowing that the

grenade wouldn't stop the undead for long. It would be different if they were alive, fire and shrapnel were much more effective against living organisms, this knowledge was in her head ... always. She wasn't wrong, the vengeful horde of the undead was chasing them, and their eyes glowing with a cold light were perfectly visible.

“The Revenants” she thought in horror. They were the undead, whose meaning of existence was to seek revenge on the living for the fate that had befallen them, even if they were not at fault for their deaths. She grabbed the pistol and fired several times, without effect, so she reached for her rifle and Alatar touched it, charging it with a technomantic spell. Then three more undead came out of the pack, judging by their elongated limbs, knife-like claws, and cat-like fangs… so they were ghouls , or even ghasts . One jumped with its claws to her throat, but then the Sparkling Hand landed two quick blows, shattering the skull of the corpse, and with a roundhouse kick almost tore the head from the neck of another, and the third Eti hit the chest with a metal hand, almost discharging it, leaving only enough power to maintain the prosthetic barely functioning. Then she grabbed the rifle and fired it from the hip. The boost shot was so powerful that it annihilated the nearest revenant . Then Alatar spewed fire and she threw in an incendiary grenade and everything was enveloped in fiery conflagration. This slowed down the undead horde for a moment.

They ran on, passing bend after bend. Eti was firing her plasma sniper rifle, and Alatar was firing his laser, which he overcharged from time to time. Those who ran closer were destroyed by the blows of Sparkling Hand mighty fists or the butts of her Rifle. They were about to reach the elevator shaft when they saw several strange two-legged bots with a gray horde symbol on their chest. They weren't here before. They dodged several shots and ran down a side corridor. Unfortunately, neither the undead nor the machines paid much attention to each other, apparently they shared quite anti-vitalist views. Finally, they ran up a rather narrow staircase. Running in startling silence, the undead followed them step by step. Alatar decided to take advantage of the terrain and cast a spell that made the stairs slippery and greasy. The

undead began to stumble and bump into each other and they became a mass of limbs and torso. They gained some time. They climbed all the way to the top and bolted the door, hoping it would halt the chase for a while. But then she saw darkness beginning to swirl before them.

“Grimmy hurry up, because we ran into the shadows, and I don't have any more grenades ...” she didn't finish, because the door broke apart with a crash and a monstrosity that was a conglomeration of dozens of bodies began to come out of it.

Dilayla, being in armor, had to go down narrow stairs so as not to slip. For the same reason, she preferred to go ahead, because if she lost her balance, she could fall on the Star siblings or Arkan-tar, it could end very badly for them. Then she received a message from Eti and cursed . The siblings also heard this message, because she connected them to passive reception of the message. Jewelstar asked.

“Corpses are moving? Is this some kind of private code signal of yours? what does it mean?”

She raised her eyebrows at him in surprise.

“Well, that means the corpses are moving. Pretty common in places like this, I should have expected it. I should took holy water and more silver.” she explained, and the three siblings looked at her completely without understanding. She shrugged and ran. As soon as she saw that the distance was enough, she called out "Attention, hold on!" and jumped. The entire staircase shuddered as its armored legs hit the floor. Without waiting for her companions, she ran ahead. Around the corner, she saw something she hadn't seen in over thirty years. Hosts of horde droids with old Horde symbols stood before her. She smiled and lowered the laser cannon on her shoulder and said.

"You don't know how long I've waited to be able to do this.” And opened fire.

Itel felt panic begin to creep over her. From the beginning, this trip to the monastery seemed madness to her. Unnecessary and pointless. Eti was in danger and she wasn't there! Just that stupid Rosie. The girl could fight, But she was erratic and deaf, she must have made a noise and woke the dead!

“You must do something!” she screamed and summoned the moonblade. Miss Daisy looked as scared as she was.

"I can… I can try to move us through the void, but only twice have I managed to take someone else she said, and panic was evident in her voice. If the dark sorceress was afraid, then the situation must have been really dire.

“I can help.” Ireanis said suddenly and closed a book and put it away.

“You?” Itel's voice was a mixture of contempt and disbelief.

Ireanis got confused and said.

"I know I'm a stupid drunk ... that I don't always control my power... I've had a bad time in... many years... But I was a war sorceress trained in Nantambu and I can help extend the spell. I swear I'll make it.” she said in a tone as serious as she had ever heard. Miss Daisy looked at her skeptically, but sighed and said.

“I don't think we have a choice.”

“I can slightly soften the barrier between the worlds, can you track them?” Rechiza asked suddenly and Miss Daisy nodded her head.

“Eti? With no problem. Grab me and don't let go for anything in the world.” said the dark sorceress. Itel hesitated as the woman

held out her hand. She hadn't been able to trust strangers for a long time, but she had no choice. She had to speak up for Eti. She held out her hand and Miss Daisy took it in an iron grip. Then they disappeared into the cold darkness.

The first thing Itel felt was the return of warmth, but then she heard screams and shrill wails. When she opened her eyes, she saw a terrifying sight. Eti and Alatar were fighting what looked like a mass of molten flesh, and on the other side Rosie faced a tangle of shadows. The Solarian heard the lament of the dead coming from tormented souls. Her mind was torn by the complaint of those who had been murdered on Horde Prime's orders , those who had died premature, senseless deaths unburied. She saw the torment of the inhabitants of the Monastery... the inhabitants of Kesler , whom she offended by the mere fact that she was alive... she felt the pain of her loved ones whom she had abandoned. Suddenly, everything stopped, because Rechiza summoned a luminous barrier separating them from the undead.

"Take care of them quickly, because I can't hold them for long!" the witchwarper screamed .

Miss Daisy and Ireanis leaned back to each other and began casting spells. The voice of the dark sorceress was becoming unnatural and her ears hurt from it. She summoned a dark vortex that sucked souls, while Ireanis hurled a green ray of disintegration that turned the undead monstrosity into a pile of ashes. The silver-haired Elf turned towards them smiling, although blood was flowing from her eyes, mouth and nose.

“Sometimes I can be awesome?! - she said and fell on Miss Daisy's shoulder.

“You did well.” she asked Eti and the others, but the feline girl snorted.

“I survived almost unscathed the encounter with the Dread Colossus created by Lady Sorrowflame, it's child's play.” She waved a metal prosthesis.

...resounding in a universe full of monsters.

Captain Moonshadow burned through the door and eyed Captain Bina suspiciously.

“Are you sure the radiation is not dangerous? “She asked calmly, trying to hide his distrust. Bina shrugged.

“The equipment shows that it is safe, I have a manufacturer's guarantee, if that satisfies anyone, although none of us will seek compensation.” she murmured.

“You know, some of us would like to have children.” said petty officer Kaert and laughed loudly.

“I don't recommend it, better buy yourself a droid , it will definitely give you a glass of water in your old age, not a grenade with the fuse off.”

The pirate captain smiled warmly.

“You're a good mother, you're not in danger of such a fate.”

Bina looked askance at her

“I would say that a pirate praising my maternal abilities is not something I would expect, but I am raising Eti and Lilka, I expect absolutely everything. Although I wouldn't say i raises them. What would you call *I don't let them hurt themselves or others?*

the burgundy-haired woman behind her mask .

“Some would say that this is the essence of raising kids.

Bina snorted.

“If you add to it neurosis, constant worrying and gastric problems, then I will agree.”

They laughed and Tonado looked at them confused, obviously not understanding the joke, and Gydwa snorted.

She really liked this Bina , she was sincere, honest and caring. She wasn't made to be a mother in the very literal sense looking at her history. She took on the task of caring for very difficult children and was doing better than many mothers who raised their biological offspring.

They were looking for the vault, but they found a trace of the reactor, so they headed in that direction. The reactor was valuable as long as it wasn't in danger of failure. It could be stripped down and sold for a lot of money in the future, like a terraforming system , though she wasn't sure that was the best decision. Sheltered, almost self-sufficient and isolated, monastery was the dream of many conflicted with the authorities, not only pirates. As long as they are able to swallow the gloomy history of this place, because she had no illusions about the fate of the inhabitants of the monastery.

The reactor turned out to be operational and had enough fuel for two more years before it self-deactivated. It seemed quite new, which was rather unusual for such places, I wonder what the monks lived on. They knew there was some sort of mine beneath the monastery though she wasn't entirely sure now. As they wandered through the dark corridors, she noticed strange symbols on the walls, reminiscent of constellations. She was horrified to find that she knew them well, though she couldn't read them. She couldn't remember where she knew them from, but eventually her past was taken from her. Bina came to her when she saw that she was examining strange marks on the walls.

"It's the writing of the First Ones , or what my kids call them, the Starlings . Eti has them on her hand, the metal one, although only she can see them.”

“The First Ones, yes, I remember that name. I've seen similar symbols before...on a sword.”

Bina shrugged.

“You have celestial blood in you. You probably saw it a thousand years ago and have already forgotten...”

She felt grief squeeze her heart.

"Yes, I forgotten..." She looked away from Bina . "I have lost so much"

"What about… that sword?" You know, maybe you can get it back…or something. said Bina, clearly embarrassed by the pirate's sudden gloom.

“Yes, I will indeed retrieve my sword.” she said to herself in a grim voice. *Even if you are the Lady of Chaos, you will pay for your betrayal, Adora*

The entire subterranean part of the complex seemed to be rebuilt ruins of the First Ones. They may have stretched for miles. In fact, she should have expected it, it was a terraformed planet, so someone was trying to colonize it. What she didn't understand was what the Iomadae and Serenae, who were apparently worshiped here, had to do with the First Ones. But what could she know about the will of the gods? She was just a pirate, maybe a little more idealistic. She experienced firsthand how painful their whims can be for mortals

She wished Rech-zar was with her Her first mate has always been with her since Jadehell . He'd know better what to think of a place like this. Unfortunately, he now had a secret mission ahead of him. He had to restore another remnant of the older races, the wreck of a strange ship, its frame covered with strange green veins. If she could get it to work, and her Verthan lover assured

her she would, then let the Lady of Chaos tremble before her wrath.

They unexpectedly received a message from Eti. The feline girl called Miss Daisy for help, because she came across the undead. Bina turned pale and ran forward, then stopped and screamed.

“Fuck! I can't find her here.” Tears of despair appeared in the clone woman's eyes.

Captain Moonshadow thought for a moment and turned to the burgundy haired girl .

“I can help you.”

Bina frowned.

“How?” she asked irritably. The Winged Pirate extended her biological hand to her.

"Trust me, I'll show you art that few have experienced. Tonado, you take over command.

- “Aye Aye, Captain.” Skittermander saluted. Bina only hesitated for a moment, then grabbed her outstretched hand, and then Moonshadow wrapped her wings around her and they both disappeared in a flash of purple light.

When they came back, it turned out that they were late, fortunately, their intervention was not needed. Only the bumbling elven sorceress was injured, for she was leaning against Miss Daisy's shoulder with her bloodied face.

“Hey Captain Wingwing . Hey Bina. Ireanis powdered the corpses and Grimmy sucked in the shadows.” Eti waved to them.” But it's downstairs. a lot of droids , and I think Fist, along with the Smarty and the three foundlings, are fighting with them, so it would be good to help them.”

Dilayla smiled as the laser beam on her shoulder cut in half five Horde droids . She felt immeasurable joy being able to repay Prime for mutilating her and her sister and for the death of her parents. The smile left the mercenary's lips when she was hit by a green beam from one of the robots' weapons. She felt a strong burning sensation in her chest, barely able to stand on her legs. She cursed violently, fired again and jumped from behind, hiding in the stairwell. She looked at the shot where the ceramsteel plate was cracked and melted. This armor should have survived a direct hit from the cannon. Arkan-tar descended first, Tallstar following.

“Undead? asked the scholar.

-“Ugh no, Horde droids are meaner than I remember. “ said the mercenary . Tallstar bared her teeth in a smile.

“Welcome to Prime's Empire .”

Dilayla nodded and said.

“I'll throw a grenade, and then we'll hit together, because we need to get to the kids.”

The others nodded, though Verthani was halfhearted. She dropped a grenade and charged, hoping that her power armor would shield her from at least some of the blast's effects. She shot from her shoulder at farther targets, tearing those close with her armored fists. Tallstar and Starla joined her, and Jewelstar and Arkan-tar covered her with the fire of their weapons. The advantage of the enemy, however, was huge and earned another post, she began to limp. Then suddenly, from the second staircase, Captain Moonshadow dressed in purple armor arrived. The Solarian Pirate wreaked havoc, and from behind her, Bina supported her with pistol shots. They were soon joined by Eti, Alatar, Rosie, Itel and Lilka, and even Rechiza. Lilka with her flaming track, and Itel danced with her silver blade. However, the greatest exterminating angel was Rosie, crushing droids with her luminous fists. The scales were tipping in their direction when she saw out of the corner of her eye that another group of machines

was walking towards them ... but suddenly a tall, blond-haired figure fell between them, holding a plasma cutt in one hand and his epee in the other. Lady Cala Grayskull has joined the fray, wreaking havoc. With grace and grace, she knocked down enemies one by one, as if it were not a fight but a dance. Even at a time like this... or perhaps especially at a time like this, she was stunningly beautiful. She destroyed enemies one by one, dodging their blows effortlessly. After a while she was alone among the shattered remains of the machines. She bowed to them all with a broad smile. She didn't look tired in the slightest, she hadn't even messed up her hair.

Fucking Mary Sue thought Dilayla...

The first thing they did after the fight was to clean up the few undead bodies destroyed by Eti and the others. Most of the undead have been reduced to dust by Ireanis . There was also a clone found by Lady Cala , most likely the victim of another living dead. To the horror of the Star siblings, Rechiza pierced our heart with a dagger and Bina shot him through the head. The three inhabitants of the Ravaged Zone accepted with some skepticism the explanation that they did it so that he would not rise from the dead. They were quite bizarre, however, and for Dilayla , preventing the spread of the undead plague was one of the duties of every soldier, except perhaps those serving in the most degenerate and despicable formations. The siblings greeted Bina in a friendly way, but were clearly intimidated by the sight of Captain Moonshadow, as well as her crew, who joined them soon after, especially since the winged woman was open about her profession. Rechiza and Arkan-tar whispered among themselves in the shadows, apparently refusing to accept that they had fallen for cheap propaganda. Miss Daisy, of course, also hidden in the shadows, watched them from a distance, while tending to Ireanis, who couldn't recover from the spell. The kids weren't sure if they wanted to be friends or come off as tough guys. The exception, of course, was Eti.

“Then why don't we celebrate this wonderful and glorious victory with a delicious broth.” said the shooter, staring eloquently at Glory, to the horror of Starla , who was trying to hide her friend.

And then there was Lady Cala. For all her distaste for the aristocrat, she was able to understand that she could command admiration, especially after what she had done in battle.

However, the one who was most pleased with the meeting with his siblings was Wrongdak. He hugged them all in turn, and Starla burst into tears. During this time, his brother's corpse was moved, covered with a cloth so as not to injure the sensitive, kind-hearted clone. Then they arranged a funeral. They dug two graves. In one they threw the corpses and ashes of the inhabitants of the monastery, and the clone into the other. Then they performed the ritual, which fell to Dilayla and Rechiza , for they were the most religious members of the expedition. Then it was time to say goodbye. As the siblings prepared to return to their ship, she surreptitiously gave them contact information for the Lord Admiral's fleet. Soon after, the siblings flew away. Then came the pirates Captain Moonshadow.

Dilayla tried to hide her distaste at the sight of star raiders plundering the holy place, because she didn't want to mess with a woman who had a reputation for not being entirely sane. It had to be admitted that the riches they took from here were enormous and the morale among her crew was significantly improved. Horde Prime took only one reliquary for himself and had Sereni's tomb destroyed , leaving only rubble. The four of her, Bina, Miss Daisy, and the winged Pirate watched as they loaded their fourth cargo of treasures.

"So it looks like this Etheria isn't such a bad place." said the burgundy-haired woman, for obvious reasons, very happy. The pirate snorted and looked at her hard.

“Beauty often hides wicked hearts. Let me be skeptical,” said Moonshadow, and they nodded their heads to Bina , though most likely thinking of completely different people.

“Captain Bina ... How did you meet Lady Sorrwflame ? I've heard all sorts of things about this woman. “asked the dark sorceress. Bina looked at her surprised and said.

“Not personally. Igzar died in a trap set by her. Only Eti survived, that's when she lost her real hand and gained the metal one. As far as I know, he is a necrotechnician who has been working for Lord Admiral Antares and his family for many generations. These motherfuckers deserve each other.” Bina said. Dilayla understood what Miss Daisy was playing and decided to get involved.

“I got an offer to work for him when I applied for this expedition. Have I lost a lot?” she asked, trying to sound as innocent as possible. Bina thought for a long time before she said.

“You did well. He is a monster.” Dilayla saw Miss Daisy shiver. “ I do not know all the facts, but the truth was much worse than the media said. It all started thirty-five years ago. The family of Antares , then Highlord Felix Antares, had ruled Tarak for centuries...certainly since before the Gap . They didn't do it directly, they never had that much power. At least until Felix's time Antares . He began to accumulate power in his hands. He was arming himself and building a navy, most likely with conquest in mind. It was the time of the Cold War between the Pact Worlds and Veskarium . The Antares family had always been in favor of Absalom , so when rebellions began to break out, the Veskas took the opportunity to send in their subversion specialists, the Pahtra siblings Igzar and Ashera . Igzar was a brilliant commander, albeit absolutely ruthless and cruel, capable to order of blowing up an orphanage to get his way, and Ashera was a saboteur and assassin ready to do just that. With their help, the rebellion flared up with redoubled strength, turning into a civil war. Bloody and brutal, fueled by the fact that the Pact Worlds and Veskarium treated this conflict as a proxy war. Both sides had done terrible things, though the Pact rulers seemed oblivious to the fact that

they had supported the tyrant. When there was a stagnation on the front, but Antares' troops were gaining the upper hand due to the superiority in resources. So Ashera had a desperate idea. With a group of the best soldiers, she went to the capital and decided to organize a coup. It was the day the High Lord bid farewell to the soldiers going to the front to fight in the decisive battle. Asehra was a great sniper, so despite great security, she did the impossible and hit Antares from a distance of over a kilometer. She paid for her act with her life. However, the goal was achieved. The leaderless soldiers abandoned their weapons. The allies changed sides, and the flame of rebellion engulfed the entire planet. Only the most fanatical supporters of the former ruler remained loyal and fled into orbit, on board the ships of the Antares war fleet ... Who, by the cruel whim of the gods, survived the gunshot. After three days of fighting for his life, he climbed onto the bridge of the heavy cruiser invincible ... and ordered the nukes to be dropped from orbit ... Just out of spite. The thing is, the others also launched a nuclear counterattack, and a total of eight million people died. Due to all the chaos, it was impossible to determine who started the excchange. Soon, the Pact Worlds and Vescarium began to accuse each other of causing this tragedy, and in the meantime Antares and his fleet escaped and began a career as a mercenary, which he was really good at. The Swarm soon struck, and Lord Admiral Antares' talent was needed. And so the criminal was made a hero.” Bina finished her story.

"And that's another reason why I don't believe in the righteousness and heroism of this She- Ra ." said Captain Moonshadow. Bina shrugged. Dilayla was grateful to all the gods that women didn't look at her and Miss Daisy, who looked like she was about to throw up. Dilayla was terrified too. “I just sent the Star Siblings into the arms of a monster as evil as Horde Prime. But maybe if I talk to Dr. Quin , he won't send the data to the admiral.” She thought, Arkan-tar had told her of their daring plan, only then she didn't care. Now was the last moment to calm things down a bit. Regardless of how suspicious it might seem, she went to look for Dr. Quin . Miss Daisy has also gone somewhere. She had to hurry. It took him a while to find Ysoka,

and when she reached her, the doctor turned to her with a smile, she said.

“Everything's settled. The message went. White Demon helped a lot.”

The mercenary felt her knees buckle under her. She turned to see a smiling Wrongdak talking to Rosie.

How I tell him he helped bring the war criminal to Etheria.

She roared as she felt fury and helplessness fill her. After Bina's story, she went to one of the distant buildings and unleashed her power by devastating the interior of the abandoned house. *How could this have happened. How could I bring it back to this?* she thought as she dug her claws into the wall, leaving deep gashes. *This time it was going to be different, this time I was supposed to fix everything. I came to redeem my actions, to atone for all the wrongs I've done. Instead, I'm in the vanguard of the monster. What's I've done*

“I'm coming in”. Lady Cala heard the voice, and without waiting for an answer she entered the room. The beautiful aristocrat looked around the devastated interior and raised an eyebrow questioningly. She told her the whole story she had heard from Bina . Her ward listened attentively, then gave a pearly laugh.

"It's a really funny and ironic story, don't you think?" the aristocrat asked, tilting her head.

I hate you, with all my heart and black soul, like nothing in the world she thought, clenching her fangs and clawed hands. Lady Cala rolled her eyes

“You're being overdramatic my dear Shadow Weaver.”

"Did you… did you know all this?" she asked, ignoring the taunt. Her ward spread her arms helplessly.

“No, but does it matter? asked the aristocrat.

She looked at her ward. For Lady Cala, the deaths of millions of beings most likely did not matter. She leaned against the wall.

“I brought a monster to Etheria.”

Lady Cala sighed and walked over to her.

“Not that I care in the least, but the situation is not that dire.”

She looked at the aristocrat in surprise.

“You see my dear Shadow Weaver. The Lord Admiral is a soldier and a mercenary, and they don't take a fight they might lose, and your She-Ra and all of Etheria defeated Horde Prime , who left behind an entire empire ready to be conquered, a much juicier morsel.”

Yes, that sounds logical, she thought, feeling a little relieved. But Lady Cala came over to her and touched her cheek with the back of her hand.

“But remember, we're both monsters. It is not right for us to be jealous that there is another one.”

Lord Admiral Antares was rushing to the bridge of Battleship Glory of the Fallen when he received an emergency call. When he entered, Mrs. Ka and Commander Reese were waiting for him.

“Look what a wonderful message our advance guard has sent us.

He looked and saw a map that included dozens of systems and a telecommunications network connecting them. Horde Prime's entire empire.

“These are the foundations on which my own Empire will stand” he thought.

He almost smiled

Dreams and memories

When she opened her eyes, for a brief, terrifying moment, she felt as if she was back in the Fright Zone, that all the events of the last five years had been just a dream. That she had fallen asleep, perhaps she had hit her head and passed out, amidst the dark corridors of Hordak's domain . That somewhere out there a Shadow Weaver is just waiting to take out hers fury on her.

“Adora!” She screamed, looking scared. If she's here, if they're here together, it's going to be okay. The two of them will be fine... just like in that strange dream... unless Adora had already left her, gone again, never loved her... Everything was just a fantasy... Then she felt something rubbing against her leg. She looked down and saw Melog. Melog is here…Melog is, it mean, everything was true. That what happened to her, good and bad, really happened. She knelt beside her friend, feeling his fear and anxiety.

"It's okay, we'll be fine. We'll get out of here... somehow.” she said and looked around. It really wasn't the Fright Zone. The buildings here were completely different, taller, but much better made. They didn't look like they were going to fall apart at any moment, like they did where she'd grown up. They were much more solid, with sharp angles, intimidating onlookers, making them feel as if birds of prey were watching them. The overwhelming canyon walls rose all around, as high as the mountains of Dryl, adding to the claustrophobic feeling. The walls were riddled with buildings and tunnel entrances, as if someone felt sorry for wasting space. Maybe it really was? She had no idea, she didn't know how she got here. So with Melog they decided to climb to the top of the highest building available to them. Everywhere she saw boards showing products or people of different races and sexes in very unambiguous poses. She blushed at the picture of two almost naked Saiche women who looked like they were about to make love. Melog turned pink.

As she reached the top, she sucked in a whistling breath as she saw the skyline of the gigantic metropolis . She was aware that Etherian cities, even the Fright Zone, were microscopic compared to cities like Icarus or Aquarius , but this stretched beyond the horizon. Millions, tens of millions of beings must have lived here. Only she didn't see any, it seemed completely deserted. She was almost happy to hear someone whistling a tune, but it was so eerie. But she ran that way.

She saw a figure wearing a long brown coat with a hood. She had a rifle with a scope on her back, heavy boots on her feet, a thick leather glove on her left hand. The right hand was made of strange metal. She could see the tip of the tail moving nervously around her feet. She was facing the city.

“So it's true, we walk ... I walk differently than the real Pahtra.” she said in a dull voice.

“Pahtra?” she asked, standing at a distance, but Melog was more accommodating. The figure snorted loudly.

“Pahtra from Vesk V, I know it, so you know it, after all, you are just a product of my subconscious.” the other one murmured.

"It's starting to get weird.”

Do you know where we are?

The other figure sighed loudly.

"Does my subconscious have to be such idiot?" Though maybe that's what it's all about? So that I can know my real self and stuff like talking puppets…”she said, her voice seemed bored and tired. The longer this conversation went on, the more confused she became, but Melog approached the other one and started rubbing against it. The stranger glanced at her companion.

“In general, I hate creatures like this, because cats are disgusting, but I actually like that one.” the latter stroked Melog . Her friend

was a man of character, and if he liked someone, she trusted him too.

"But whoever I am, I still don't know where I am." She stepped closer. Other one shrugged.

“It's Atrax... Probably not long after I was freed. I didn't live here long... at least after I was freed. But i came here often these few weeks.”

She thought for a moment and asked.

"I don't know anything about Atrax , but have you heard of Kesler ?"

The other one snorted.

“Kesler has been destroyed.” She replied firmly.

“By Horde Prime ?” she asked sympathetically, but the other laughed.

“Crooked Snout and his dumber brothers? Don't talk nonsense! The swarm ate him” she replied sharply.

She was amused because Crooked Snout was a very funny nickname, but the rest of it made her uneasy.

“Swarm, I don't know what it is, I don't know this part of the Galaxy.”

She was silent for a long time, until she began to speak in an angry tone.

“So it's you? Listen to me, leave me alone. She turned around, and even though she was wearing a mask, she could see her eyes, a cat with blue spots. "You are dead. Dead for over twenty years.”

And then she woke up...

She got up and looked around. She was at the river, a huge river that stretched out to the end of the world. It flowed through many islets, barren and swampy. The waters of the river were black and dead. Everything around was dead, completely lifeless, except for the hideous frog-like creatures splashing in the dark waves. She had spent the last few weeks on Icarus , or rather its smaller continent, Dedalus . It was an extremely exhausting time, she never expected that an ordinary diplomatic visit could be so grueling. It's good that Scorpia and Perfuma were here with her. I mean, there weren't a lot of them here, which made the whole place even scarier. She closed her eyes and reached for the power, She spoke the words.

"For the honor of the Grayskull. – and she felt her body fill with euphoria and ecstasy. Multicolored light flashed. She shifted into She- Ra's form and tightened her hand on her sword. Now she was ready to face anyone…anywhere. Actually, anywhere was a very good term.

"Is anyone here? Let him come out and introduce himself!" she called into space, and for a moment there was only silence. But then she heard the splash of oars, and a small rowing boat emerged from the mist. It was piloted by a tall man dressed in black robes and wearing a wide-brimmed hat. He held an oar in his hands. His face was hidden in shadow, which made her think of the Shadow Weaver. The thought made her take a fighting stance and glare at him menacingly.

"There's no reason to be so angry. After all, I'm only doing what you asked me to do, you summoned me, so I've come. As a side note, I'll just add that this whole transformation is much more spectacular than I remember." said the figure in an old, biting voice.

She didn't like the newcomer's words very much. Neither himself.

"Tell me who you are and what you've done with me and my friends..." She said confidently with the power penetrating her through.

“Well, courtesy first. I am Charon, the Horseman of Death. The leader of the Horsemen of the Apocalypse from time immemorial and the undisputed Ruler of Abbadon” He bowed to her simultaneously politely and mockingly. She snorted contemptuously.

"The title-throwing has already begun, hasn't it? Whoever you are, free my friends, or you will suffer the same fate as Horde Prime “

Charon laughed derisively.

"Oh, what threatening words, and you have not the slightest proof that I have done anything wrong to you or your friend. Perfuma sleeps soundly, and so do you…” said the Lord of Abbadon . She smiled, feeling relieved. She laughed embarrassed and said.

"So it's a dream, I've talked to dreams before." She scratched her cheek. "I think I shouldn’t mix fruit liqueur and those Perfuma’s cookies."

Charon looked at her with disapproval so great even Shadow Weaver couldn't

“No, it's not a dream. I talk to you in sleep because that's the easiest way to contact you, because death and sleep have a lot in common. And I wanted to talk about the great discourtesy that happened to me on your part.” The eye beneath the hat flashed a crimson light. She sensed an aura of terrible evil from him, even greater than that coming from Horde Prime . Behind the Horseman appeared a clock, gigantic as a mountain, made of black and silver metal. She couldn't tell exactly what hours it was showing, the symbols were completely unfamiliar to her, but they seemed wrong.

"Your actions caused the End of Time clock to turn back, which made me very sad.”

She gripped her sword with both hands, ready to fight, but suddenly she sensed a new power coming. She also had an aura of evil around it, but much older, both more primal and subtle. She turned around and saw him floating on the ground. He had a crown of flames and an inverted Ankh on his chest.

“We didn't know that the Horseman of Death started stalking. It's so disappointing” said the newcomer.

Charon growled.

“Why are you interfering, Creeping Chaos. You want to protect this girl? Do you like this trophy?”

Creeping Chaos laughed.

"Do you really think she needs anyone's help?"

"Excuse me, but haven't you noticed that I AM HERE?" she cried, waving her sword.

Charon looked at her and stared at her for a long moment before he said

“No, I don't think so.. All I can say is that I won't forget you and your fiancée. I have a surprise for you. Fear the Shadow of the Moon and the Slave of Ice.

The clock struck the hour.

Death was all around her. The earth was scorched and poisoned. The trees were Dead and Twisted . The sky was filled with smoke from countless fires. She saw destroyed vehicles and ruined cities. In those five years, she had seen death and destruction more than any of the princesses, but only her power could heal the

wounds inflicted by Horde Prime . But with each such healing, she absorbed the pain and despair left by the Horde. Scorpia was very supportive of her, as was everyone else. But there were pains that could not be shared, had to be endured alone. She has always felt a connection with all living beings. Usually she felt an overwhelming joy about it, a happiness that came from the universe itself.. But that also meant that she felt the suffering of all beings. She wanted to scream for their pain and cry for their despair. But only she could heal the earth, bring it back to life. She had seen terrible things up close. She saw them both with her eyes and with her heart. Everyone thought only the fight was hard. But healing also took its toll, especially when he couldn't help the suffering she witnessed. Adora understood. She, too, faced pain and despair that not even She- Ra's power could ease. But she had to go on because no one else would take her place. Though she didn't know how much longer she would last...

But this place... it was dead... No, it was being killed, it was dying in mortal agony . She guessed it was a dream, she had practiced lucid dreaming more than once, with mixed results. She remembered falling asleep and knew where she had been before. But it was too real to be a dream. She perceived her surroundings with all her senses. Burnt smell and bitter sour taste in the mouth. The pain of fingernails digging into flesh as she saw the school, half dissolved in acid. She could read inscriptions, for example on signposts. One of them pointed to Greater Kesler and the other to Eastern Kesler. There must have been a smaller Kesler somewhere... Wherever she was. At first, she thought this place was a reflection of her experiences in the last few weeks, but if this wasn't a normal dream, then maybe the universe was trying to tell her something. Perhaps it wanted to show her the fate of planets attacked by Horde Prime . Make her realize how much more work lies ahead of her to heal the wounds he inflicted on the Galaxy. Only here was something strange. She had never heard of Kesler , but Horde Prime must have ravaged hundreds of planets over the course of those hundreds or perhaps thousands of years. However, she did not see the remains of the Horde machines, nor the bodies of the clones anywhere. In fact, she

hadn't seen any bodies anywhere, perhaps the universe had kindly spared her the sight of it. But she had seen tracks, knew a bit about tracking, though she didn't eat meat. Some of them probably belonged to the inhabitants of this planet or vehicles belonging to them. Others, however, were left by completely different creatures, like huge arthropods. There was no shortage of those on Etheria, but… something didn't suit her here…

She heard the music when, after an hour or maybe a day, it was hard to tell in her sleep, she reached an area covered with hills. She didn't like it much, but she could say the same about Street Music from Icarus . Everyone had their own taste, she had no right to judge anyone. She immediately ran in the direction from where she was coming, maybe she will meet someone or something who will explain to her what is going on here. But as she ran to the top of the hill, she was speechless with horror.

She saw the battlefield, huge, stretching as far as she could see. Everywhere were smoking wrecks of vehicles, tanks, and others whose uses she did not know. There were bodies of soldiers of different races everywhere. Heaps of corpses of huge insects of all kinds, many larger than tanks, surrounded them. Sometimes they were stacked higher than She-Ra. No one gave any signs of life, although there were sounds of fighting in the distance. On the horizon she saw a city surrounded by a glow of flames. Tears welled up in her eyes, she had never seen anything so terrible. Then she saw a figure playing. She held in her hands something like a guitar or lute, the strings of which made sounds that hurt the ears. She was clad in a silk robe with a hood that was gleaming black. Her hands were almost white. She sang in a gentle male voice.

Can you feel the pain of this world?

Shout out, because I can't feel anything anymore.

Can you hear the scream of this world?

Tremble, for I have become indifferent.

Can you see the despair of this world?

Cry because I can't.

He said standing in the midst of death, then lifted his hood. She groaned seeing his face. He was a young man with black hair and a pale complexion, but his eyes were pierced with sharp spikes. It was too much for her.

“Leave me alone. I've had enough of everything already.” she screamed, and the young "man" was surrounded by rhizomes binding him, and then ran blindly ahead, away from this place.

She wasn't aware of how much she was running, at this point it probably didn't matter anyway. Finally she stopped and knelt crying. All she wanted to do was go home and hug Scorpia ... and Adora and everyone she met. She already wanted to wake up. Suddenly she felt as if someone were hugging her tenderly, not physically, but as if a friendly soul had hugged her. She opened her eyes and looked around. She was in a clearing full of horsetails and ferns. They were the first living plants she had seen in this place. She smiled kindly at them, but then she sensed someone's presence. She stood up abruptly and assumed a fighting stance, because in front of her stood one of those terrible insectoids that she had seen so recently, although the other ones were dead ...

Please don't be afraid of me. I won't hurt you, she heard in his head. She stared at the creature in surprise. She was dressed in ceremonial robes and wore a chitin crown on her head, she exuded gentleness, friendship and ... great sadness. She immediately liked her.

“I'm sorry, I thought you were one of those terrible insectoids”

The creature lowered its head as if depressed.

I am one of them. These are my children who were taken from me long ago. Now known as the Swarm, they are wreaking death and destruction across the galaxy to my despair, she said in her mind, "I am Hylax . Forever Queen," she added.

She bowed courteously and said.

"It's an honor to meet you, Queen Hylax . I am Princess Perfuma, ruler of Plumeria and princess consort of Princess Scorpii, ruler of Scorpion Country or Centimori as it was formerly known. You're definitely nicer than that horrible individual who accosted me out there on the battlefield."

Hylax exhaled loudly through her windpipes.

It was Zon- Kuthon . Lord of Midnight . He is also a lost child. Once his name was Dou -Brai, he was a good being who appreciated beauty and joy, like his sister Shelyn. Now he is the patron of suffering and envy. the Forever Queen explained.

"But what does he want from me? I never seek conflict with anyone, if I can help him in any way, I will, just let him explain to me what he needs." she said in a desperate tone. Hylax sighed sadly through her windpipes.

You're a good girl, Pefuma. But you also suffer a lot. And this suffering attracted Zon- Kuthon . Unfortunately, there is nothing you can do to help him. Once he wandered behind a dark tapestry where only my unfortunate children can wander without fear. My poor children... Listen to me. Only you can I contact without much difficulty, for you listen to the music of the universe. There's something going on in the galaxy that I don't fully understand, and so do everyone else, except maybe Creeping Chaos and the other Outer Gods, but they're not worth turning to for advice, because they'll give answers that will shatter even the strongest mind. All I know is that it has to do with my poor children, your friend Adora , and an Artifact called the Eye of Sereni . You have little time, because they come. There comes a hunger that cannot

be satiated. Remember, Hylax told her , and then she heard a much more wanted voice coming from somewhere outside.

"Darling, Honey, you must wake up because they are coming”

Sari wandered aboard the *Memory*, a research ship belonging to Doctor Sidonius, a galaxy-famous scientist, esotericist of unparalleled skill, an ancient vampire and above all, her father. She didn't have much to do, because already five years ago, after the fall of Jantar, he abandoned most of his projects, except for the most important and mysterious one, to which he decided to devote his unlife. He amassed vast resources for this purpose and gathered many allies, though many of them resented. One automaton from Carurystal, for example.

“Oh, Miss Sari, how nice to meet you.” said Prince Zed, bowing low to her. She rolled her eyes.

'We've been on one, not so big, ship for a month. We meet ten times a day, it's rather boring. Say what you want from me.”

The eyes of the ancient mechanism glowed with a mysterious inner glow.

“Your father wants to regain what was taken from him, his greatest treasure. I am looking for my kindred, but what are you looking for Miss Sari. I don't think you were driven here to the most cursed part of the galaxy by the loyalty of a child to a parent. At least not only”

She smiled, revealing the Dhampir's long fangs .

“Revenge. Revenge for my mother's death. I will destroy Light Hope and everything she loved.”

Joan has traversed the countless decks of the *Dreams of Eternity* Void Galleon. She didn't feel tired. Her tormented biomechanical body couldn't feel it, or much else. Only pain. Not very strong, but constant. She was never free from it. The Order did not want to believe her. There was nothing strange about it. After all, they were partially responsible for her fate. Even Dilayla refused to listen to her, offended at the world, refusing to look into her sad eyes. She didn't want to accept the fact that it was her fault too. After all, she didn't protect her on the Minitar . Only Captain Blazebringer listened to her and promised ... redress. Unlike her body, no one could help her, not even an Ancient.

The galleon was gigantic, once hundreds of thousands of beings could have lived here, and there were entire ecosystems on board, modeled on the environment of lost planets. Now many of them were dead, and the crew was five, not counting the captain, who had been in temporal and cryonic stasis for many years . He suffered, as did she, though his anguish was much deeper…

She entered the sector where the End of Time Arsenal was kept. All weapons except the "Defensive Systems" floated in the void and huge casemate. Each of them was the size of a starship and had its own propulsion and even AI, though in this case she wasn't sure if that was the right word. Each had its own personality and temperament, and using them was more like bending demons to your will. But that was what she did as mistress of the armaments of this ancient ship. She looked at the list of weapons:

Fireflies: Multi-guide missiles with fusion plasma warheads. Explosive power approx. ten kilotons

Scrapers : Beak Material Weapons: Explosive power of approximately one hundred kilotons

Cleaners: Laser Beak Weapon.

Destructive Punishment Blade: Relativistic Magnetic Weapon. Explosivepower of about ten mgt

Fist of Doom: Gauss' Relativistic Weapon. Power of about fifty megatons

Hunter of Eternal Night Demons: anti-matter anti-air weapon.

A spear piercing the heart of a mountain: a ray piercing up to a kilometer of rock per second

Hornet Sting; Anti-ship electromagnetic cannon

Wreck Burner: Gamma ray to clean ships

Tear of the Sun: Plasma Cannon. Destructive power continental scale

Antiworld Drop: Antimatter Cannon. Destructive power continental scale

Restoring Natural Order: Electromagnetic Cannon on a Planetary Scale

Awakening of the Primordial Gods: Earth-shattering weapons

Godfather's Clenched Fist: Gravity Cannon. Destructive power planetary scale

Purification: gamma ray on a planetary scale

The universe traitor's weapon: a beam of micro black holes. Destructive power planetary scale

Venom of Hearts: Supernova weapon

Summon Firelord: Causes a solar blast that consumes planets

Abyss Key: Turns a star into a black hole.

It wasn't much compared to the Heart of Etheria , but with the Arsenal they had a chance, albeit still a slim one, of destroying Eternia once and for all.

Tales scary and joyful

She groaned as a short exclamation woke her up. She was sore from riding all day, and tomorrow they will be climbing. She was no longer young ... It’s mean, she was in her prime, ready to fight and go to the end of the world.

“What's going on there?” she exclaimed, looking around with sleepy eyes. Frosta stood up summoning ice fists. Entrapta poked her head out of the sleeping bag she had hung on a line on the escarpment, making her look like a caterpillar cocoon or the prey of a very large spider. looking around curiously. Unarticulated groans came from Lance and George's tent . They were probably as sore as she was, after all, they were much older and not so seasoned with the hardships of hiking in the wild, although she should not forget that they lived and raised children in the Whispering Woods... They had some experience. Finally she looked at Catra. The Great Marshal sat panting, beads of sweat glistening on her forehead, and Melog cuddled up to her. She seemed scared.

“I'm sorry, I had a bad dream. I didn't want to wake anyone up.” she said a bit embarrassed. She smiled at her.

“Nothing happened.” she said as gently as she could. “And so the moon rose, we have a long way to go before dusk today. It's good to start the day as early as possible.”

This girl has the right to have nightmares like no one else. She thought sympathetically. Even today, Spinny would wake up screaming in the night because of what Horde Prime had done to her. And Catra was…much closer to the deranged Horde lord. She has also undergone purification. She heard about this cruel procedure from a one clone. It was excruciatingly painful even for

an obedient clone, she couldn't imagine how much someone so tough must have suffered before she was broken. *And Shadow Weaver's upbringing will turn anyone's soul into armor of steel* she thought. *Well, you mustn't forget about her childhood yet. It also left its mark on her.*

Catra smiled weakly, then made a face as if she was sick and went to the side.

"Oh, morning sickness, something's up" she thought. She and Spinny had been postponing motherhood until after the end of the war for a very long time, and now they were trying to catch up at an accelerated pace, though Quickling and Greypaw had already taken to their home before end of war. There was no point in Adora and Catra waiting so long if they wanted to change diapers, even though they had time, and they were young and full of life. They might as well have waited. It was also logical that Catra was going to give birth, after all, no one knew how the transformation into She- Ra would affect the pregnancy, although Catra could care more about herself. On the other hand, how could she know about such things? Who would tell them what they didn't even know, that they didn't know. Shadow Weaver probably didn't care about explaining such things to her wards. She couldn't imagine what their first period was like, they probably thought they were bleeding internally.

She just hoped Adora knew all this. Yes, the heroine of Etheria sometimes had to be pushed when decision paralysis seized her, but it was still necessary to agree on everything. But that was none of her business.

After a while, Catra returned and seemed to be feeling better. Entrapta and Frosta were already busy making breakfast, while George and Lance were doing their morning "System Check." She decided she should go too and help the others instead of gossiping to herself. She cast a glance at Catra and saw that under the mask of apparent indifference, she was hiding anxiety, maybe even fear ... Well, it really wasn't her business ... But was it really?

They heated breakfast and water on a portable plasma stove Entrapta had built, though she and Catra had to keep from stepping back to a safe distance. Entrapta's inventions were certainly safer now, especially since she had a child, or so they thought, but old habits were hard to shake off. Lance and George made cappuccino , they even had soy milk. Admittedly after the full adoption of Greypaw Spinny relaxed the rules a bit and allowed dairy and fish to be included in their diet, but she tried to avoid eating non-vegan food… although she sometimes made exceptions. She couldn't resist a few slices of greasy smoked fish. But he didn't eat the bacon, though it was so tempting. Frosta fed Melog fish and dried meat, although he was a little ashamed of this snacking and glanced sideways at Catra . The latter, however, was thoughtful and worried, which also affected her companion, and soon the magical cat lay down on the ground slightly blue.

Entrapta was eating her rations that looked like cupcakes or cubes of… nougat. She offered them to Lance and George, who ate them with some effort. Frosta much more openly tossed her portion to Melog , who, having sniffed it, moved away from the food as if it were about to bite him. Entrapta had never been able to cook, though given her special dietary needs, this was not surprising. Although it was sometimes fascinating that such a wise woman, who could remember the chemical composition of every substance she came into contact with , could not cook a decent broth. From Scorpia, she learned that Hordak was responsible for preparing meals in their household. She couldn't know what to think of his skills, at their wedding and their baby's birth party, she ate only a few tiny cookies prepared by Scorpia . It was the hungriest party she'd ever attended.

She couldn't understand how an intelligent woman like Entrapta could get involved with someone like Hordak. He was… just Hordak , the invader and self-proclaimed ruler of Etheria. He was responsible for the death or ruin of tens of thousands of lives. He was the one who allowed Shadow Weaver to torture her father to death. He was the reason Greypaw and Quikling were orphans

Entrapta spoke of him fondly and lovingly, as if he were the kindest person in the world. She didn't understand it. More than once she and Spinny wondered if he had brainwashed her or chipped her in some fancy way. Although her wife assured her that it was completely impossible, she still sometimes looked suspiciously at the nape of her neck. Until finally, even the purple-haired woman noticed it.

"Do I have something on my neck?" She pulled a mirror out of her pocket and began to examine herself in it, so she missed the indulgent look cast by Catra at the ruler of Armoria She coughed in embarrassment.

"Because I was wondering. How is your life with Hordak because… you are quite an unusual couple." she said carefully, trying not to giggle nervously.

"Hordak is a wonderful laboratory assistant." Entrapta began. " Thanks to him, my work turned out to be three times more efficient. He has a wealth of knowledge that comes not only from Horde Prime, but also from decades of research conducted in the Fright Zone. Without his help, I would not have been able to carry out many of the most important experiments that have significantly increased our knowledge and made Etheria a safer place. And above all… I love him." A gentle, almost blissful smile appeared on her face. "We were both single for many years. I know this is hard for you to understand, especially for you, Catra , but we were all prisoners there in the Fright Zone. He understands that I see the world differently, because so does he. He's always been different than his brothers and Horde Prime... He really understands what love is and can be tender... in many ways..." Entrapta smiled wider and she was pretty sure she saw the ambiguity in that smile . "Besides, we share a lot of common interests. Science, technology, ping pong… I guess that's how a good marriage should be. George and Lance share a love of books... Catra and Adora tried to kill each other."

Catra laughed, but surprisingly cheerfully for her current mood.

“We have a lot in common, but not this. In fact, we've been best friends for most of our lives at least... except for that one year... But you're right, we always understood each other very well, almost read each other's minds... There's only one thing we've never been able to realize.”

She smiled at the feline girl.

“We with Spinny initially where at each other throat. Our lands have long been at odds, and after we lost our lands, my grandmother wanted to show everyone, especially those wimps of Windcrest, that Armoria wasn't dead as long as we were alive... So I challenged "that stupid hottie chick" to a "Friendly Duel." I thought that I, a warrior trained since childhood to fight an n owner of artifact that generates energy nets, would have no problem kicking…” She looked at Frosta . “kicking the ass of a wagon-raised girl… and she kicked my ass. “ she said and laughed at her memories. “I could not believe that. I had got obsessed with Spinnerela . Nothing mattered to me but that pink-haired girl. I forgot everything and everyone. Even about the Horde. I collected every piece of information about her. I decided to pretend to be friends with her. I was nice and cute, I invited her to game night… And it turned out that I liked her. She was smart, brave and sweet. I felt that I felt something more than just frenship. Only then my grandmother intervened and told her all that was just trick to examine her. Spinnerella got very angry with me, and we didn't speak to each other…until the Great Battle. I was severely wounded in the head there, I still have a plate there. I thought I was going to die and… I confessed my love to Spinny . We got married practically on the battlefield… We joked that I had to hit my head to say I love her We've been together for eighteen years now… Geez, Spinny got chipped on our thirteenth anniversary , so we moved our anniversary to Victory Day… So it looks like we'll be able to celebrate our anniversaries together as three couples next year!”

Catra groaned.

“First we have to survive this wedding.” said the feline girl resignedly.

She laughed warmly.

“A wedding is nothing terrible, you will survive it.”

"Let's hope..." Cattra said , smiling thoughtfully.

After breakfast, they washed up and went on their way. They were at the foot of a mountain range slightly lower than the Drill but much less explored. Few people lived here, mostly a few pastoral settlements and a few bands of nomads using arc-powered skimmers. Even Frosta couldn't say much about the place, though she was their guide anyway and was quite good at it.

She and Melog decided to go ahead with Frosta . She felt better than ever. The crisp and fresh mountain air sobered her, banished her dark mood as the wind blew away the dark mists. She wondered how she had once preferred the bitter and stuffy atmosphere of the Fright Zone to clean and healthy air. She often didn't understand what was good for her and what made her happy. And despite all the worries that plagued her, she was genuinely happy. And with any luck, that won't change.

“Catra, Catra! Look!” Frosta called her. Although the girl was small in stature, she was very agile, although of course she was no match for her. In a few bounds she was at the top of the pass where the ice princess stood. As she stood beside her, she inhaled sharply, and Melog shimmered in various colors. She stood at the entrance to a wide valley covered with silver-blue bushes. A river flowed through it, the waters of which reflected the blue of the sky. It was fed by a glacier rising on top of the nearby mountains. The glacier was shattered and cracked. Gigantic fragments of it broke off from the main core, presumably in an earthquake triggered by Entrapta when she hacked the black garnet. But what

made her jaw drop was the city. She could only see part of it through the binoculars, the rest was hidden under the ice dome, but what she saw was extraordinary. Dozens of high towers with large windows, reminiscent of huge chimneys or insect mounds. She couldn't see the doors or the streets, as if the inhabitants didn't need them to travel around their settlement. She wasn't sure of its size, but it was certainly much smaller than the city she'd seen in that dream... Though it had an aura of strangeness around it, as if those who built it had completely alien minds and physiology. She shivered.

“Isn't it great to be on a great adventure again! Ancient cities, terrible monsters and wicked villains! Frost exclaimed, jumping for joy.” She smiled happily at the girl's reaction.

“For now, there's only the city, no monsters, let alone villains, to be seen around.”

Frosta waved her hand as if it were a completely insignificant detail.

“Uncle Lance said that there lived a terrible many-eyed monster, although no one had ever counted his eyes, but we will, we are the Invincible Seven after all.” she said, full of unbridled enthusiasm.

"We're the Invincible Seven now?" she asked, feeling Frosta's humor getting to her.

“Sure! It's you, me, Melog, Netossa, Entrapta, George and Lance. We are seven and we are invincible, that is, we are the Invincible Seven! And there will always be a villain. The world is full of them. For example, one chancellor. “ Frosta suddenly became serious, becoming a real ice princess. “The Chancellor… He wanted me to take the title of Empress and separate the Kingdom Snow from Etheria, so that I would betray Glimmer. But I refused him because it was stupid and I would betray Glimmer. And we are friends. Will you tell Glimmer about this? That we're still friends and that she can count on me?” she asked, and tears suddenly

appeared in her eyes. She took her in her arms and hugged her as tight as she could.

"Of course I'll tell her, but Glimmer has never doubted your friendship." She assured Frosta , but inwardly she wasn't so sure, for she remembered that the Chancellor had spoken to Storm Heart, Sister of Shadow Weaver, in his Lady's absence. *This is how all evil begins. From dark disputes in the shadows*

They waited for the rest of them, especially Lance and George, who then spent the entire walk discussing vehemently about who the people of this town were. She was thinking about her dream at the time. That girl... she had cat eyes and heterochromia, though of a different kind. She knew about Kesler , and... *You've been dead for over twenty years* she said, and she was twenty-four after all. Before, she would have thought it was her subconscious trying to tell her she felt dead inside. But she had never felt as alive as she did before marrying her beloved. Besides, the dream was all too real, which was unsettling. Her companion had the same opinion on the subject. Melog always dreamed her dreams. She needed to be sure, so she decided to ask Lance and George one thing.

“Have you ever heard the word Pahtra ? she said, trying to sound as innocent as possible.

“Yes, that's the word some cat people like you used to describe themselves.” Lance said, and when he saw that she had gone pale, he asked, "Is something wrong?"

We walk differently from real Pahtras

“Nothing special. I just heard that word somewhere . And the word Vesk? Does it have anything to do with them?” she asked, trying to control herself.

“No…" The librarian shook his head, and for a moment she felt relieved. "The word has something to do with reptilians like your

friend Rogelio ." Vekse , Vaste , Vesku , or possibly the oldest Vesk is the name of their homeland. It used to be thought that it was some lost land, but now I think it could be another planet... You really look bad...” he asked, seeing that she turned green.

“It's nothing, absolutely nothing ...” she stammered with effort, trying to control the nausea, she barely noticed Netossa's eloquent look .

They traveled until late in the afternoon, and stopped near a city. They did not want to visit it after dark. They still had plenty of supplies thanks to what Alice was carrying. They must have left the vehicles at the foot of the mountains yesterday, but besides her, no one was afraid that someone might steal them, well, that's what Etheria was like... They set up camp and made a fire. It got quite nice and cheerful, like when traveling with a buddy . Frosta suggested telling scary stories . Lance told of a terrible book that ate people to get life into its pages. George told the parable of the sorcerer's apprentice, Netossa told the story of the terrible octopus-like Scyrlledi living in the depths of the oceans. Entrapta knew none. Finally, Frosta presented a delightfully gruesome tale of Ithaqua , the great cannibal.

“And all you could hear was Ithaqua crunching their bones. Om nom om.” She finished and everyone looked at her expectantly. She smiled and looked up at the starry sky.

"Most of the scary stories I know come from Shadow Weaver… Not scary stories like that… I could tell those too, but I don't think that's the point. She… had a real knack for storytelling. She told them with her whole being imitating voices and even did tricks with magic to add color to the whole story. Of course, she always replaced all the monsters with princesses. Although she didn't always have to change them. I'll tell you about the blood-sucking princess. she said and began to tell her story. She had no dark sorceress talent, but everyone sat listening, even Entrapta began taking notes. When she finished, she sobered up.

“That's all ... and not all because this story is true ...” She looked at the bewildered faces of the others. “I'm serious. I recently fought one of these in Mystacor, though he wasn't a princess. - she began to talk about what happened in Mystacor quite recently , and everyone listened attentively to her with growing amazement and disbelief. When she had finished, Entrapta began to jot down frantically.

“It's fascinating. Do you suspect animating magic, reviving animating nanites , or a new kind of neural chip ? Have you examined the object?” asked the inventor in an excited voice.

She blinked twice processing the information provided by the inventor.

"I'm not sure if I understood you correctly, but since it was Mystacor, I'd bet on magic, but I don't know much about this kind of thing." All I know is that I don't like the idea that the dead can come back. And the words of this crazy woman. Halo...” she fell silent. Netossa gave her a sympathetic look. Frosta and Entrapta looked fascinated, though probably for completely different reasons. George thought for a moment, exchanged a few whispered remarks with his husband, and said.

"What you're describing sounds like a vampire to me, one of the more powerful not dead ones."

“One of? Are there other worse ones?” she asked, and she and Melog bristled. Lance and George nodded together and Lance said.

“Of course. Liches, Devourers, Raveners... according to legend at least.”

Netossa snorted.

“So what else awaits us? Will we encounter a dragon or maybe a dragon-vampire right away ?” she said in an extremely annoyed voice.

"To be honest, I once read about a dragon-vampire . Lance said. “Her name was Ashaq Annihilator . She lived on the other side of the world and served another dragon, the most feared of all."

She groaned.

“No exorbitance, some myths will always remain myths..."

Not that far away, both on a galactic scale and counting in Drift time, Lady Sorrowflame was praying aboard the heavy cruiser Invincible . She prayed sincerely, with all her dark soul and dead heart. She summoned her master Dachak . As for over three hundred years, and as for over three hundred years, silence answered her. This time, however, she answered for the first time.

“For this silence, I will draw a scream from the throats of millions. I swear by my dark heart I, Ashaq Annihilator.” she said, tears of blood streaming down her cheeks.

Bitter truths.

He was lost in thought while training with Dilayla. He was so happy to will be back on Etheria, to his friends and brother. What he will tell them about his travels and listen to stories about their new adventures. Then he saw all those destroyed planets...he warned them that they wouldn't find anything there...they didn’t listen to him and saw what his Big Brother could do when he was mad, bored or just on a whim. He was as evil as he was powerful. He was…everything he hated…he knew that hate was a bad thing, the one feeling everyone should get rid of, but for Horde Prime, an exception could be made…

It wasn't his fault, he told himself. All these planets were destroyed years before he was created. He wasn't responsible for what had happened ... but he felt guilty. Had he not been cut off from the collective hive mind, he would have been just like his brothers. He would carry out even Horde Prime's nastiest orders without batting an eyelid . Without hesitation, he would be ready to kill anyone just to gain his approval. Though no one ever deserved it . Neither the little brothers, nor any of the gods that the so-called priests spoke of, nor even She-Ra herself, were worthy of him... No one who was not created as his tool could understand how much power he had over life. thoughts and hearts of his clones he possessed. His elder brother was unable to free himself from his overpowering influence for thirty years. He knew his new friends didn't blame him for his brothers' sins, but he couldn't. Now, however, he had free will and only his choices depended on whether he would not repeat the mistakes of his brothers. He was free at last, and now his life belonged to him alone...

And then he saw the message from this Horde Ultimate and couldn't believe what he saw. His brothers finally had the opportunity to go their own way, break the shackles and make their own way… and they chose… something like this. It wasn't

even a Horde Prime imitation , it was… something hideous. Distortion of distortion, deception within deception. He couldn't fathom how his brothers could willingly bow down to someone who wasn't even a shadow of his Big Brother. It was all supposed to be different. They were supposed to live a joyful and peaceful life like him, and they chose to go to war with those who saved them!

He understood the idea of lying and cheating, and he wasn't too bad at it, though truth be told, he didn't like telling untruths. He felt like he was doing something fundamentally wrong. He had had to weave and avoid the truth many times during these last few years, but he seldom lied. And that drow... and his brother... How could they say such horrible things. Adora wasn't a Chaos Mistress but a liberator, Glimmer wasn't a witch, and Catra was definitely not that Shadow Beast! But the most terrible thing was how they portrayed Entrapta and his brother. She wasn't a monster, and she loved his brother very much, and for some time he had begun to wonder if their feelings weren't more… affectionate.

The worst part was that others could believe these disgusting lies. Dilayla knew the truth, roughly speaking, and the crew of Bina's ship seemed skeptical of Horde Ultimate's slanders, just as Lady Cala did. The rest, however, seemed concerned. Arkan-tar and Rechza were concerned even after meeting the Star Siblings. He was very happy to meet his friends who transported him to the planet where he met Skittermander . He was happy that nothing had happened to them. As Starla hugged and kissed him, they talked for a while in private.

“It's good ... that you're okay ... because we were starting to worry a bit.” Jewelstar said .

"My brother meant he was afraid those little creatures would eat you up." Tallstar added with a warm laugh.

“No, adult Skittermanders wouldn't eat anyone.” he said in a reassuring tone. The siblings looked at him confused.

"What's 'do you mean *Adult Skittermanders wouldn't eat'?*" Jewelstar asked cautiously .

“Well, the young ones can suck the juices out of someone until dries you out. But just a bit of caution and you'll be fine... Skitterwanders are worse , they can suck your guts out. Once, Emily and I helped drive one away. We got a medal for that. You also have to be careful how you talk to Vesc , because if you do it the wrong way, they will challenge you to a glorious fight, although they are nice in general ... In the galaxy, everyone is generally nice, although you have to watch out for many. Like the Drow, the Duergar, the Dragons, the inhabitants of Eox and Aucturn …" As he spoke, their faces seemed more and more worried.

“That's great... and are your new companions... treating you well? Jewelstar asked with concern in his voice.

“Yes, they are very good to me. They rescued me from the captivity of such a Grag , although Eti almost killed me, but it was partly my fault. Eti is ... She and Lady are extraordinary, although Eti is very shy ...” he explained and felt that his heart was beating faster with delight.

“It's the shooter, right? I wouldn't call her shy... more like a little unsettling. Talstar said carefully..

- Yes ... But she is ... - he did not finish, because he saw that Bina was calling him. “Just don't say anything about the Heart and stuff like that. My brother asked me to…' he was explaining hastily, but Jewelstar put his hand on his shoulder and said reassuringly.

“Don't worry about it, we're careful. None of us want to make an enemy of Adora, Catra and especially Glimmer. Dread to think what she would do to us if we caused her trouble.” He laughed warmly and patted him on the shoulder.

He was sorry to hear about the fate that befell his brother. Another of them died completely unnecessarily, although his

death, unlike the countless multitudes of his brothers, was not due to Horde Prime's will but because he wanted to serve Horde Ultimate ... He was starting to hate him too. How could he take away the freedom he and his brothers had just gained. And why was he doing it? What for? This question kept resounding in his mind, but he couldn't find an answer to it. He'll have to talk to his brother about everything. He will surely understand and be able to help somehow. He and She-Ra, I'm sure they'll work something out. Together! Yes, that's a wonderful idea!

He decided to vent his anger during training. His friends told him not to contain anger and rage, because it can lead to terrible things. Besides, after these few weeks he also lost some stamina, they had a training fight and the mercenary did not fight with full vigor, as if something was bothering her. He had the impression that some of his friends became sad after the events in the monastery. He felt sorry for them, Rosie told him about what had happened there. He felt sorry for the inhabitants of the monastery, the next victims of Horde Prime , though he was horrified by the fact that they rose from the dead because of their hatred. Fortunately, the three sorceresses defeated the undead. His deaf friend was delighted with the heroic feat of the sorceresses, especially Miss Daisy. They liked this strange, gloomy woman. She was protective of Rosie and… Eti, much more than Lady Cala…. The aristocrat once again proved that she is more than ordinary inhabitant of the Galaxy. Alone, she defeated a whole host of Horde droids . She was almost like Adora … No, almost like She-Ra, though of course Adora was She- Ra . At least that's how he understood it. Thanks to Lady Cala, they were victorious… But why was everyone acting like they had lost?

“Arghh Today I have no head for this. The mercenary growled and wiped her face with a towel.

“Did something happen? I feel like you've been worried lately.” he asked, lowering his protective gear. Dilayla looked at him as if she wanted to apologize to him for something.

"No... just you see... recently I found out something..." She was embarrassed and ashamed, as if she had done something very wrong and now she had to admit it. "Listen Wrongdak ... I have to..." she began, and then suddenly they heard a joyful call from the entrance.

“Hi! Is Eti here?” Rosie asked. Suddenly *Almost Catra* appeared behind her.

“Hey Sparkle hand, I'm here.” she said, and he got the impression that her voice was somewhat sad. Rosie jumped up in fear .

“Could you please sneak up? the intern asked.” Eti shrugged and said in a voice that sounded resigned.

“Yes... I think I could.”

Rosie nodded and asked.

“Can we train together...?”

Eti tilted her head to the side and pricked up her ears.

"So you're not afraid of kicking someone's ass again like you did to Stinka?" She stared at Rosie, who thought for a moment and said.

"A bit, but I think I was pretty good with the undead and I think I should practice. Well, to be better, because we don't know what adventures await us.”

“Great attitude Rosie.” Dilayla called, smiling warmly at the intern. Then they heard footsteps and Itel entered the training room. The elf stood next to Eti, on the other side of the one occupied by Rosie. He sensed that there was some tension between the girls, but he didn't understand what caused it.

“Hi Dilayla! Bina is calling you to kitchen.” she said in a cheerfully. Dilayla got confused and said in a rather strange voice.

“I'm coming. Will you take care of Mr. Wrongdak ? He will train with you. Just don't hurt him.” She looked meaningfully at Eti, who shrugged. The other two girls nodded. The mercenary left and the three young women went inside.

“Can I train with you?” Rosie asked Itel, who looked at her confused.

“Of course.” Solarian said cautiously .

“We will train shooting. Eti said. While her friends stepped onto the training mat and they approached the shooting range. He didn't like guns, but he was better at using them than most soldiers. He chose the shape and parameters for the practice weapon and put on the virtual Glasses. The cityscape came up first, but Eti growled furiously under her breath and switched the projected landscape to some grassy plain.

"Well, now you're going to fight The Swarm” said the feline, and then the Attack began. He wasn't in the least afraid of insects, so the onslaught of swarm components didn't impress him as much as on others. But still, the sight of countless hosts was terrifying. Although the shooting range was only used to simulate the properties of the weapon, the appearance of the opponents was only cosmetic, but it was enough to make him realize the horror of fighting the scourge of the galaxy. He could only hope he didn't have to face them. After half an hour, he had had enough and asked them to train on the exercise equipment. He started working out with the barbell and Eti started stretching.

“You shoot really well. Where did you learn it? he asked after a long time, and the girl began to look at him with those sad eyes of hers. Finally she said in a low voice.

“There where you did, Wrongdak” She looked at him seriously, waiting for him to fully absorb the meaning of what she said. He drew in a deep breath.

“You are… Just like me and… like Bina” he said. The ship's captain's confession shocked him. He wanted to talk to her about all this, about how people like them feel, how those whose minds were… created with all knowledge, instead of slowly growing and shaping throughout childhood. Who were deprived of the right to shape themselves as they wished. But somehow there was no time for that recently… And now it turned out that Eti is also someone like him and his brothers. Everything they did was done to her too. Now he understood better why there was so much anger and bitterness in her… and sadness. Only if she's like that, so Catra too... How will he tell her?

Itel stopped the fight and watched them closely, as did Rosie.

“No, not like you. I'm nobody's clone. I was made. I was designed and brought to life two thousand two hundred and twenty-five days ago. There were others like me, but they were failures, mistakes, defects. They are all dead… ALL!” she shouted suddenly, probably for the first time since he had met her. “Only me is left, because I am absolutely perfect, awesome and unique.” She fell silent and sat quietly, the entire training room fell silent.

“I'm so sorry…” Only he could say. She shrugged.

"Me too..." She said in a barely audible voice.

Dilayla was walking to Bina with a nozzle on her shoulder. *They must have guessed something, maybe Eti eavesdropped something she has ridiculously good hearing* thought the mercenary . In fact, she wouldn't be surprised if the captain wanted to leave them all on the nearest habitable planet. In fact, the law was probably on her side. They concealed important, one might even say, crucial information from her. But such an act would end tragically, neither Lady Cala nor Miss Daisy would allow their plans, however dark and terrible, to be thwarted. They would easily pacify the crew, unless Rosie sided with her new

friends, and she certainly would, but in that case she would have absolutely no way of predicting the outcome of this clash.

In fact, she considered letting the others know who was coming. Others, however, were of a completely different opinion. An hour after returning to the ship, all members of their expedition, except for Rosie, locked themselves in their cabin. Together with Miss Daisy, who had told Lady Cala everything beforehand, they informed the rest of what they had learned from Bina . There was silence, as it always does at such times. Finally, she growled in an annoyed voice.

“Have you heard me? It turned out that we were bringing a war criminal to a place that had already suffered enough from the war. I guess we should do something about it, shouldn't we?”

Arkan-tar, who had his hands in his pockets thoughtfully, shrugged.

“What are we supposed to do?”

She looked at him in disbelief. She spread her arms wide and asked, barely holding back a scream.

“I don't know, warn the others, for example, or something?”

Rechiza looked at her with those metallic eyes of hers, dead and unmoving.

“For the time being, we have only the words of Bina to support this thesis , who is neither a very reliable person nor has she learned all this firsthand. All her information comes from this Igzar , who as the Lord Admiral's sworn enemy, who is not a reliable source. I see no reason for us to change our plans because of a few unproven rumors. said the Witchwarper, her voice hard, as if to drown out her own doubts.” Dr. Quin nodded.

“I agree with Rechiza . The situation is as follows. There is a possibility that the Lord Admiral was involved as one of the many participants in the civil war, in a nuclear weapons incident. But

surely the inhabitants of this Etheria were trying to use against all of us weapons that could bring destruction to you all. I guess it's better to choose a known bastard than criminals we don't know." Ysoka said.

Dilayla couldn't believe what she was hearing. Her companions had displayed such a level of cynicism and cowardice that she wondered how they could look at themselves in the mirror. Support came from where she least expected it.

"How strange it is that everyone prefers to wade into the thicket of their mistakes, even if steel thorns were to tear their soul apart, instead of accepting their own imperfection and coming to the light of truth, to suffer the consequences of their actions." Lady Cala said with a note of loathing in her voice. Dilayla was absolutely sure for the first time that the noble was being absolutely honest with them. Everyone looked at her in surprise, except for Miss Daisy, who looked at her suspiciously.

"While we cannot tell our traveling companions, which I regret, sooner or later the people of Etheria will learn the true nature of the Lord Admiral, for the true nature of every being will come to light sooner or later. So it's good to let it happen on our terms. Otherwise, it's very easy for the people of Etheria to link us to this individual, and they won't be wrong. This could end very badly for us. Therefore, it would be wise for us to warn the authorities of Etheria about our ally in an appropriate way. I remind you that we owe nothing to the Lord Admiral, after all, he deceived us all, we will only stand for the truth. Lady Cala said confidently. Everyone in the room was amazed, Dilayla probably the most.

What are you up to beautiful bitch

Yes, though. she was silent, though she didn't like it at all. She wanted to warn the Wrongdak at least. She almost did, but then Rosie came in and she missed the opportunity, and perhaps the courage. The worst part was that even if she screamed the truth

to the entire galaxy, it still wouldn't change the fact that they had brought in an individual who had bombed his own planet with nuclear weapons. They brought on those who destroyed a monster that took absolutely everything from her. It was indeed a gratitude worthy of Zon- Kuthon .

Bina was waiting for her in the kitchen. As soon as she saw her, she smiled cheekily and pointed to a chair. Feeling both relieved and guilty, Dilayla sat down, and Bina placed a bottle of vodka on the table.

We need to talk about our children. said the ship's captain in a half-joking tone. Halfway only.

"No one is getting married I think?" said the mercenary pushing the bottle away from her. Bina raised an eyebrow.

“I wouldn't be so sure. Rosie and Eti like each other very much, Eti somehow even learned sign language, which sometimes happens to her ... Only Eti is a very specific young woman and in addition Itel fell in love with her, and you don't even realize how hotheaded she can be that's why I'm asking you who Rosie is and how much we can trust her, because if yo6 say that she's just an intern, forgive me, but I don't believe it.”

Dilayla considered her answer for a few moments, then sighed and said.

"I don't know Rosie much more than you do, I've only known her a few hours longer, but she reminds me of my sister, so I decided to look after her." All I know is that she comes from a lost colony of people like her, and that the capsule containing her was found by the crew of a research vessel belonging to Kemanis University. They took care of her, I don't know anything else. And now you tell me who Eti is, because I won't believe that she is bald Pahtra. You're protecting her past too much. If you want, I won't say anything to anyone.”

Bina thought for a long time before she said.

“Eti was created by my Father as part of a long-term research project, but you probably suspected something like that, if you want to know more, you have to ask her yourself.” and then something shook the whole ship. An alarm sounded for the bridge.

In less than a minute, everyone will be there. It was quite cramped because of that. The ship was now piloted by Mr. Ilemshaw , and Alatar was the navigator.

“It knocked us out of the drift.” Dragonkin said

“Drift drive failed?” Bina asked fearfully.

“No, nothing serious. It's just that the nav detects two Starstones, it's about to reprogram it to ignore one. explained the technomancer.

“What, two Starstones? Rechiza asked in disbelief. This is the most powerful artifact in the galaxy!" Where is the other one?”

- It's almost funny. It looks it is on Etheria.” he laughed nervously. Lady Cala and Miss Daisy stared at each other in utter astonishment. And then there was delight on the aristocrat's face, and horror on the face of the dark sorceress.

The Burden of Heroism

She didn't want to kill him, she really didn't. But he woke her up. She was having a particularly bad dream, and she had really bad ones. Only that wasn't an excuse, she had committed a crime and she would have to face the consequences. Though maybe he'll find someone to fix it. Whoever makes him move again, his heart will beat anew. She just needs to put it together. She won't be wandering everywhere with the remains, because everyone will know... Who was she deceiving? After such a kick nit, and what absolutely no one will restore it to its original state. Even with all of She-Ra's power, she won't be able to undo what she's done...

She murdered the antique clock from Eridani, again. Already the third this year. The first was annihilated when a mechanical wyvern sprang out of it without warning , announcing with a piercing scream that the hour had struck. Another was destroyed by Swift Wind for the same reason. Next they destroyed with Catra when they made love. One was destroyed by Melog when Bow's nephew threw him a ball, and another by Bow himself when he practiced shooting blindfolded. Twenty-three clocks died in Brightmoon in total ... so they could never say they had enough clocks. The people of Eridani had a strange habit of gifting them with various gear-driven mechanisms. They regarded such gifts as an expression of the highest respect, for they were often based on designs of items dating back to before the Loss, some extremely important date whose meaning was difficult to understand for most of the inhabitants of Etheria, let alone her, for whom the world before Hordak’s arrival was almost like a fairy tale. But Bow, Glimmer, and especially Scorpia usually got wind-up toys of some sort, Scorpia had a whole room full of them. Well, the ruler of scorpions did not murder gifts. It was actually amazing how much delicacy she could find in those pincers of hers. Perfuma knew it best.

“She-Ra Adora, princess of power, chosen of the light, slayer of Horde Prime, savior of the known worlds, Master of the universe, is everything okay?” The guard's voice rang out.

“Firstly, many times I asked to be called simply Adora, secondly, are you aware that if there was someone here who threatened me, you wouldn't be able to list all these titles?”

“Not She-Ra Adora ...”

“You are not aware?” She interrupted him hopefully.

"I can't agree to not naming you properly. Disregard for convention leads to Anarchy, anarchy leads to Chaos, and just wait for another Horde Prime to emerge from Chaos. The future of the universe rests on my shoulders. I can't fail.”

She blinked twice.

“Just bring the tea . she asked resignedly.

"What She-Ra Adoro ..." the guard began, but she didn't let him continue, she just roared.

“WET!”

The guard left. Inwardly, she could only hope that it would at least it will be warm. This has been her life for the past two weeks. Giving speeches, cutting ribbons with a sword, hearing speeches, watching a performance about how she defeated Horde Prime . The latter tended to be strange, the locals outdoing each other in making the ruler of the Horde more and more grotesque and exaggerated. She'd met him a few times and he was definitely scarier than any comic buffoon she'd seen here. At first she tried to explain that it was completely different from the performance but Scorpia and Perfuma convinced her not to. It is surprising that the couple enjoyed the performances so much. After what the Scorpion princess had been through, she expected her to feel bad about seeing Horde Prime again, but instead she laughed at the oddities of all these versions...

"They made thirty eyes on this one, and they're all cross-eyed." She laughed, though then she worried whether it was appropriate to laugh at people with a crossed-eyes.

She was glad that no one was interested in her whole story. Hers and Catra's. She preferred not to wonder how she was portrayed here… Her fiancée liked to laugh at She- Ra and the rest of her friends, and even at herself in the Double Trouble Theater, but those shows had their limits and a bit of good taste… though recently she had the impression that Sea Hawk was slowly becoming the main character. However, some people might exaggerate here...

But it wasn't the plays that frustrated her the most, it was the expectations... of her and of She- Ra ... still of her. It was… hard to bear. On Etheria, most people understood that she was… a normal woman, but everywhere else she was seen as a superbeing , a perfect creature who was asked for so much, so much more than she was able to give. She thought she was free of the Shadow Weaver, and after leaving Etheria, the Shadow Weaver turned out to be others.

She sighed and swept the remains of the clock under the huge canopy bed. She was somewhat accustomed to luxuries after living in Brightmoon for years, so the room didn't overwhelm her, though she was assured that it was worthy of a queen... But without Catra, she might as well have slept on the cold stones, and even the narrow bunk by her side was a hundred times more comfortable. more comfortable than a down pillow.

She smiled proudly to herself. At first glance, there was no sign that there had ever been a clock here. Of course, the cleaning lady would probably find the remains, so she probably made her extra work ... though as she'd already noticed, almost everything she used suddenly became very valuable, so probably the remains of this clock will be worth much more now than they were before. This display of adoration was so disturbing that she took many items with her, such as dirty underwear or used sanitary napkins, preferring not to think about what they could do with them.

Tea was finally brought to her, as well as supper, though she had not ordered the latter. She got enough banana bread with honey to feed all three of them. But Catra would snort, she hated honey. But she made herself an early dinner. After she ate, she felt really refreshed and left the room with renewed vigor... Where four guards were waiting for her, staring at her adoringly.

“She- Ra'o Adoro princess…” the same guard began, but she cut him off by raising her hand.

“Did I ask for something? No titling and don't talk to me about Chaos again!” she screamed. He looked at her with undisguised resentment. She wished Catra were here with her, she was much better at intimidating annoying types. “What are we planning for today?” she asked, feeling more tired than before bedtime.

“Princess Perfuma and Princess Scorpia have gone to the Kings Gardens and then they will go to the valley of Kelimene , where together you will heal the area where the vacuum booms were used.” said the guard with a renewed sense of humor.

“Great, take me to them.” she asked, but the guard frowned

“Unfortunately, first you will have to answer the questions of the inhabitants of the North Dedalus' Democratic People's Republic .”

She sighed resignedly.

“All right, go ahead. I want it all behind me now.”

The current capital of the North Dedalus' Democratic People's Republic, Clytemnestra, was a large city, at least for her, with almost two hundred thousand inhabitants, although there were larger cities on Icarus . It survived only because there were many old monuments here. Horde Prime had a warped love of art, and avoided destroying old buildings unnecessarily. Temples were the exception, usually he either destroyed them or remade them so that he seemed to be the main and only inhabitant of these

places. Now she was in She- Ra's form in a huge amphitheater. There were several hundred people sitting here, and most of them were children or so-called journalists. For the first two quarters of an hour, she answered questions from the youngest. About what she likes to eat (anything but a lot), whether she brushes her teeth and cleans her ears (of course!), about her favorite color (gold and blue). She actually liked that. Only then did it become unpleasant. A tall and handsome woman in a red army beret and dress uniform asked her.

"Is it true that She-Ra, the so-called savior of the Galaxy, was a Horde soldier?" Her voice was hard and judgmental, as if it were an interrogation.

“Well, yes, I was ... But what does it matter?” she asked confused.

"You're not asking questions here, I'm asking you, and since I'm asking you, it obviously matters." she said sharply, with a reprimand in her voice?

“Excuse me, but who are you?" she asked indignantly.

“I'm Claw , Ivory Claw. Former resistance member and decorated veteran, now a journalist working for the state newspaper *Only Truth*, but continuing. Is it true that you have risen to the highest position in the Horde on Etheria?” She didn't take her eyes off her.

“No ... I mean, I was appointed force captain, but it wasn't the highest position. The highest was Lord Hordak's , and Second in Command was next, but” She didn't finish as Ivory Claw cut her off.

“Is it true that until the time of "leaving" from the Horde, you were a pupil, even a protégé of the Second in Command known as Shadow Weaver?” said the journalist. The children stared at her confused, but the adults began to whisper among themselves.

“Yes, but I wouldn't say to…” Ivory Claw She nodded and cut her off again.

“Wasn't this Shadow Weaver formerly known as Light Spinner and taught at a university called Mustacor and was widely respected there and sat on the university council?” she said, and stared at her obviously judging.

“Yes, but how do you know that?”

Oh that was a very good question. Even on Etheria, this was not common knowledge.

“I conducted a journalistic investigation, that's all you need to know, I can't say more because I would have to reveal my sources, and this is against elementary professional ethics. But back to the pertinent question of whether your defection coincided by some strange coincidence with the finding of an ancient artifact giving you She- Ra's powers.” Ivory Claw tapped her notebook with a pen.

“Yes , but it had nothing to do with …” she had a growing impression that this woman was accusing her of something, but she did not understand what.

“Are you engaged?” the journalist asked unexpectedly.

"Yes, my fiancée's name is Catra, and our wedding is on Victory Day." she said and smiled at her thoughts.

“Was your fiancée also a member of the Horde, you even grew up together?”

“And what about this? There were hundreds of cadets like us in the Fright Zone…” She could feel the fury rising inside her.

"But it was your fiancée who took Shadow Weaver's position after she overthrew her and led an offensive that nearly ended in a Horde victory, and before that she almost destroyed your planet with your sword, and before that she carried out a terrorist attack that resulted in the kidnapping of your queen, and then led to an ecological catastrophe on a global scale.” The journalist slowly came down to her, tapping the notebook in the rhythm of her

steps. Her hands tightened on the sword. Even though the woman was two heads shorter than her, she didn't look away, but looked into her eyes as if challenging her.

"It... wasn't like that... What are you getting at!" she screamed, barely holding back. He will not allow Catra to be maligned ! Who were they to make such accusations behind her back!

“I'm going for the truth , because only the truth can save us, isn't it?” the woman said smiling mockingly. "And just one more question. Is it true that you were brought to the Horde's headquarters by Hordak , who was the leader of the Horde on Etheria?” Ivory Claw raised an eyebrow questioningly.

She blinked twice. Everything the reporter said was true, but somehow twisted so that it no longer had anything to do with what actually happened.

“What are you insinuating.” she said sharply, barely controlling herself.

Ivory Claw snorted.

"Is it how you call the pursuit of truth on your Etheria?" She turned to the crowd and continued. “Please, my compatriots, think about it. The leader of the Etherian Horde finds an infant, a representative of an ancient, supposedly extinct race, and takes her into his care. He gives it to his right hand for training, There he trains with his future fiancée. She then deserts when she finds an ancient artifact that only she can use and accidentally befriends the future queen. During this time, her future bride gains one of the highest positions in the Horde. After about a year of fruitless wrangling, they manage to snatch the planet from its mysterious hidden dimension, and it immediately falls into Horde Prime's clutches. The queen and fiancée are kidnapped aboard the *Velvet Glove.* However, the tyrant who is responsible for the deaths of millions of our countrymen does them no harm, and a few months later She-Ra frees them both with virtually no resistance. Shortly afterwards, while Horde Prime is trying to

activate a weapon capable of destroying us all, She-Ra somehow makes the ruler of the known worlds disappear and nothing is known about him until now, so we all assume he is dead, possibly right… perhaps. These are the facts. We see a lot of coincidences here . Sometimes coincidences are just coincidences... Sometimes... Come to your own conclusions.” The journalist finished and took her place in the audience.

She felt everyone's eyes turn to her. She was used to it and accepted it, but this was different. There was fear and accusation in them. Theirs eyes pierced her like steel spikes. She didn't understand what Ivory Claw was up to , what she wanted from her. But she didn't have time to think about it, because suddenly everyone in the audience started bombarding her with questions.

"How many people have you killed in the service of the Horde?" the older scarred veteran asked.

“Was it all arranged from the beginning?” a tall woman asked.

“Will Horde Prime come back? I'm scared!” cried a frightened child.

She looked around the crowd and felt her heart choke with fear. So she did the only thing she could think of, a very silly thing. She grabbed her sword and jumped several hundred meters, then another, and another, to be as far away from the accusing eyes as possible.

It only calmed down on the outskirts of the city, in the area since Horde Prime's conquest . Was it the old holy quarter, or was it a temple distrikt? Somehow... Anyway, the Lord of the Known Worlds had most of the inhabitants wiped out, but he spared the buildings, they were too beautiful for even he to destroy... But what he did was even worse. He ordered to replace the images of the so-called gods, spirits and saints with his likenesses, sometimes triumphing over the beings who were worshiped here.

She didn't understand the point of building temples and attending them, at least until recently, but what Horde Prime had done seemed wrong even to her. But it was the right place, because hardly anyone lived here. Although the images of the insane tyrant were removed immediately after the victory and the temples began to be rebuilt soon after, very few returned to this district. It was said that this place is haunted, that this place is haunted by the ghosts of those who died here. But she wasn't afraid, she didn't believe in such things. Shadow Weaver liked to tell them scary stories, usually about scary princesses. The headless princess. The wraith princess. The bloodsucking princess. It was all lies, as was most of what came out of the cursed sorceress's mouth. Everything she said was only meant to bend others to her will, to bind their minds with dark bonds. She and Catra were freed from her only when she sacrificed her wicked life for the only good deed... But if she was free, yo why is she thinking about her now.

It's all because of this dream... she thought to herself, rubbing her face with her hands. She was standing on the roof looking at the gloomy panorama of the district. She was still agitated and felt the power flowing through her, not letting her return to her natural form. *I just remembered one of those scary stories or novels that Mermista throws up to me" nothing else,* she thought, but she knew she was lying to herself. The dream was too real, too real… and this evil… two kinds of evil, different but equally wicked. Just who were Charon and Creeping Chaos? The former seemed to know her. He knew She-Ra just like Horde Prime. So he was at least as old... Did he know Mara? Or one of the previous She-Ra? She knew nothing about them, other than a few hints from Madam Razz. Didn't that mean she didn't know anything about herself?

She groaned. Why does it always have to be so complicated?

She jumped down still in She-Ra form. She needed to rest for a while, be alone for a while, away from all those people who adored her, who wanted something from her… who accused her of

not doing enough . The building on which she stood was not very impressive, rather modest, almost devoid of decorations.

“Come on in, don't be afraid.” called a voice from inside, strangely resonant, as if it was coming from many places at once. She sighed and stepped inside, still trapped in She-Ra's body. Lately she had been having more and more trouble returning to her true form, at least when she was agitated. She didn't want to go in there, but she didn't want to run any further, she was tired, tired of it all.

She went inside. The interior was as modest as the exterior. The only decoration was the image of a black butterfly on the wall. It was simple, even conventional, somewhat in the style of ornaments so favored on Etheria. It did seem quite old though, which was quite unusual considering how Horde Prime hated such buildings. There were no chairs, benches, or anything of the sort needed to receive those who wished to worship the being to whom this place was dedicated. Only her inner glow illuminated the place. There was one person here, a woman of about forty, somewhat stocky. She turned to her and found out she was blind

“Welcome to the Temple of the Black Butterfly. Silence Between.” she said in a strong and melodious voice.

She smiled at her.

“Maybe I just need silence.” she said bitterly.

“In silence, the voice of the soul is heard best. Call me Zei . I have been taking care of this place for a long time, even before the occupation.” the woman explained to her.

“Voice of the soul, it's wonderful. One more voice willing to tell me what to do or what I'm already doing wrong. “ She looked sadly at the floor.

“It is not difficult to always do everything perfectly and not make any mistakes. It is enough to know everything and see everything”

She shivered as Horde Prime's favorite phrase was mentioned

“He said so too.” she said darkly and a little suspiciously.

“He said a lot of things and few of them were true. No one, except maybe one, knows everything, and absolutely everyone makes mistakes.” the woman said in an amused voice.

“But not every mistake depends on other people's lives. very many. She knelt, crushed by the weight of heroism. The woman walked over to her and touched her cheek. She immediately drew back as it reminded her of the way Shadow Weaver had treated her.

"Sorry, I just usually touch other people's faces to know who I'm talking to… though in your case I don't have to." I sensed your power and… sadness from a distance. Truly, a great burden is upon your shoulders, She- Ra'o , liberator... child of the void.”

Tears sprang to her eyes involuntarily and she felt them trickling down her cheeks.

“Sometimes I don't have the strength anymore. I'm so tired ... “ she said, exposing her soul to this woman. Perhaps she had done wrong, but in that very moment she felt herself becoming Adora again .

“Fate can be cruel and often gives us more than we can handle, especially when we try to be the good and selfless ones. We can only bow before it, or face it with our heads held high, but it doesn't matter anyway.” Zei said sadly, but also warmly.

“It's very pessimistic.” she said bitterly.

“But also true ... However, fate can be deceived. At least for a while, come with me to my apartment. I have something for people like you. Lost and… lovers separated by an interstellar space, and as far as I know, you fall into both of these categories…” Zei said . She was a little wary, but followed her. They found themselves in a small flat at the back of the sanctuary.

It was cramped and cluttered with backpacks, traveling clothes and rations. Apparently, the keeper of the sanctuary did indeed often help lost souls.

“I work as a massage therapist and collect donations from those few travelers who visit my sanctuary before interstellar travel. That's why I buy these things. Listen to me, you need to be alone for a while, get away from She- Ra as much as possible for you.” Zei said . She smiled at her, but spoke in a serious tone.

“I have two friends. I have to inform them ...” she explained, but the blind woman interrupted her.

“Yes, I understand ... These two princesses from Etheria. Don't worry, I'll let them know everything. I have some contacts here and I have a lot of respect…”

She smiled and told them what she had to say, then packed up and went on her way, not even noticing the black butterflies that usually accompany lost and separated lovers.

"Honey, Flower, you must wake up, because they are coming" she heard and with a battle cry she sprang up to fight, ready to repel the Hive's attack. She saw a large group of children and Scorpia staring at her in bewilderment. She laughed nervously and discreetly withdrew the vines she had summoned to immobilize her attackers.

"I'm sorry, I had a bad dream… And I got a little scared." She explained clearly embarrassed. She dozed only for a moment on the bench, and her wife covered her with a blanket. The dream… it was terrible, it seemed to last for weeks, and it was so realistic. But now she was in the "King’s Gardens," though there was no king in North Dedalus' Democratic People's Republic. Sometimes the galaxy could be confusing.

Horde Prime had said to keep the place, but only white flowers from a distant planet could grow here. The garden had to be

perfect, otherwise the inhabitants would be punished. At first, these flowers looked cute, but after hearing this story, they started to annoy her. Now, however, new plants have been planted. Many of them were very similar to the plants living on Etheri, she had read about others, so now she could tell children about what grew here and, using her magic, showed them flowers in various stages of blooming. Scorpia also listened to her attentively, although she had heard her talk about it more than once. Her wife was so lovely...

Showing the children around calmed her down. The dark dream passed, now she felt the warmth returning to her soul and she was fine again. Then they began to prepare for the journey to the valley of Kelimene, where she was to help heal the land there. She knew it would be painful, but she knew someone had to do it. Then came word from Adora. A letter was delivered to them, the messenger was a quiet boy dressed in black, who immediately disappeared somewhere. The content of the letter was as follows.

Adora must experience silence

To hear the voice of her soul

She will join you soon

And then the letter turned into a butterfly and flew away towards the gardens...

Shadow of the Past - Things worth living for

She woke up. She heard her groan and immediately ran to the bed where Asindesa di Vir lay. The Hellknight looked much better now, but she knew all too well how deceptive poisons can be. Many, after the initial very severe symptoms, was seemingly subsiding, although the real damage done to the kidneys, liver or nervous system sometimes showed itself after many hours or even whole days, when it was already too late. She developed several of these herself to get rid of enemies in the Fright Zone. Here, she had the latest medical achievements and healing magic at hand , but their doctor ... had a heart attack. For a long time, she refused to call for medical help from a nearby town. For most of your life, asking others for help has been a sign of weakness that others will sooner or later use against you. She was raised to believe that only the paranoid would survive. Eventually, however, she broke through. Asindesa di Vir couldn't die, she would do anything in the world to save her. She wasn't sure if what she did mattered. Medics performed transfusions and injected auto-healing systems, but they couldn't do anything she couldn't. So she had to wait. It was a torment. She could be extremely patient, such as when she waited in her cell for Hordak's sentence . She was patient now, too, but this time it was much more difficult. Previously, she had been waiting, like a spider, to weave her daughter into her web of intrigue and sacrifice her for her own selfish interest. Now she had to wait for the verdict of forces over which even the so-called gods had little influence. She knew the people of the castle were whispering about her, about what had happened there in the swamps of Kranor Rill. Soon the whispers will turn into rumors, and they will spread around the area, and she will have to answer questions about what happened to the other members of the expedition. This could mean serious trouble in the future. After all, she was responsible for the deaths of many prominent members of Carurystal society, though their deaths were not her goal. It's hard, she'll deal with it somehow, she lived

thirty years in the Fright Zone, judges from a planet that had never known a real war could do nothing to her. All that mattered was Asindesa's life ... and of course that damned mission... Damned indeed.

She was now looking at the woman who had become so important to her. Asidesa Di Vir opened her eyes and when she saw her, she smiled slightly and asked.

“We won?”

She smiled the same way.

“We've lost horrible.” She wiped the knight's forehead tenderly, but she got up and looked around the room.

“We are in your castle, I mean Lady Cala 's castle ...” she stated in a serious tone. "What happened to Sir Rakima ?"

She hesitated as she thought about her answer. She could have lied, said Vesk had fallen right after the Lady of Blades had lose consciousness. Nobody would ever know the truth. Instead, she said.

“I left him there. I had enough power to take only one of you. I chose you”

The Hellknight looked at her for a long moment before speaking.

“I see.” She didn't add anything else.

She went out and ordered the servants to bring the broth with noodles, and after the meal she helped Asindesa Di Vir to wash herself. Then she went to her office for the first time since leaving on that futile and doomed quest. She wanted to make sure nothing important had happened while she was away. First of all, news from Lady Cala, for she could call upon her at any time to fulfill her… obligations to Creeping Chaos. After all, it's been almost five years since her awakening... But nothing of importance has appeared, not even encrypted with secret symbols

known only to the servants of the being with a thousand's of thousand faces. Then she decided to eat something, more for appearances than for real need. Then she went to her private bathroom to finally wash off the stench of the swamp. On the way, however, she came across Leris . The half-elven maid was overjoyed to hear that her mistress had returned safe and sound from the voyage to Kranor Rill, until she cried. A sensitive, nice girl.

"Is everything okay?" Leris asked in a fearful voice.

"Yes, everything will be fine with Asindesa di Vir." she said, and felt a wave of relief finally wash over her. Leris nodded, smiling strangely sadly.

Asindesa di Vir decided to stay in Castle Grayskull after all, though she could have gone to any clinic on Carurystal. Who would refuse the Lady of the Blades of the Order of the Eclipse? The Hellknight had iron health and recovered quickly. They also spent a lot of time together. It started with the breakfasts they ate together. At first, they talked about everyday life in the castle, what it's like to work as the administrator of an ancient castle, and about their neighbors. Eventually the conversation turned to the history of House Grayskull , but she didn't know much about it, and what she knew she couldn't say. So she redirected the conversation to Asindesa's exploits during the War with the Swarm, though the Hellknight was not very florid about her achievements.

"War is mostly about waiting, getting into right place and chaos. Mostly chaos. I was just a bit luckier than my comrades who fell. The Swarm is… it is an enemy that no one can imagine without fighting it. He is not merciless… No more than a hurricane or a meteor shower. Innumerable components coming at you wave after wave. All you can do is killing them to the moment when the Swarm will find it too costly to fight. It's very... methodical work, without glory ... but there's never any glory in war, that's what

they teach us in the Order from the very beginning. How was it with you?" asked the Lady of Blades, looking at her carefully.

"How was it with me?" she asked genuinely surprised. Asindesa laughed warmly.

"We in the order are not that much blockheads. I know what I see. I can recognize someone who has dealt with the military more than many so-called officers. You saw the struggle and death with your own eyes." the Hellknight said. She replied with a sad smile.

Oh my dear. I have seen death and murder also beyond the fight. Many innocents died not only on my orders ... Like that unfortunate fool, Netossa's father. Hordak then yelled at me for a good hour before I told him that he had ordered me to get information out of this man at all costs, that was the results he should expect. Well, it didn't change the fact that I had tortured him to death… though I didn't really have to. I had many other options to choose from… she thought bitterly. She spent the rest of the meal wondering what and how much she could say to Asindesa ... It wasn't until they were about to get up from the table that she spoke slowly and carefully.

"For thirty years I served in an army that was trying to conquer the world I came from. I was the right hand of the one who wanted to submit us to a tyrant more insane than the rulers of Azlanti."

The Lady of Blades regarded her carefully but not judgmentally . Finally she smiled mysteriously and nodded.

"I suspected something like that." said the Hellknight. She lowered her head, afraid of what would happen next. Rejection, revulsion… that Asindesa would leave and never see her again. However, the knight of hell got up and put her hand on her shoulder.

“I understand ... no, I can imagine that it must have been very difficult for you. When you're ready, you'll tell me everything.” She smiled reassuringly.

The following days passed in a strange atmosphere, full of anticipation and unbearable, but also soothing silence. They didn't talk, at least not about important things, they just enjoyed each other's company. They ate meals together, drank tea together, showed her guest around the property. Finally, when they were at the top of the castle tower and she felt safe watching the leaden gray sea stretching to the horizon, she began to confide.

"I was once supposed to be a priestess… though that word wasn't used in my country. We lived in isolation, despised foreigners, looked down upon them as savage barbarians. My mother was a clan leader, one of the most important people in our society. She was, or maybe still is, I haven't heard from her for seventy years, a very principled and strict person. She hated opposition, treating everyone as her pawns in clan games that were pathetic and utterly uninteresting to anyone except her and a few other similar women. I was destined to be a priestess, and my sisters were destined to be commanders of the clan army and head of the Assassins. I was more talented than my sisters, and they envied me, but what I had, the position I could achieve, was not enough for me. I was born with the gift of magic, but on our islands I couldn't develop it ...” she said, thinking about the past, to which she practically did not return for decades of service in the Horde, only recently, on Carurystal, she began to think about it more and more. "It's because of these damn rains. They remind me of my Motherland"

"So you ran away," Asindesa stated , guessing correctly about her past. She nodded and began talking about her semi-happy life in Mystacor . That she had great talent and limited power. About the difficulty of accommodation and slow gaining of acceptance. About loneliness and frustration due to lack of purpose in life. About the invader's arrival and how she met Mikah . She spoke of

the ritual, the effects of which she did not understand at the time, as if it were an accident, fearing that the Hellknight would connect the facts and understand who she had summoned then. With that, she ended her story. She continued it in the following days. She told about her service in the Horde, gaining position and power, about the spiral of evil she fell into. About the battle and how she punished Mikah for saying a few words of truth. Finally, the moment came when she had to tell about her greatest Sin. It was unusual for Carurystal, cloudless, stars shining, a single white moon full. "I guess it's a good time," she thought and, taking a deep sigh, said.

“I almost ruined my daughters life”. she said, staring at the horizon.

“Is it in your state that you can have children?” asked the Lady of Blades in surprise.

“Probably not, though I honestly don't know. I never thought about it. No, they were orphans, one of the many I looked after, though these two were especially close to me... Unfortunately for them. One I treated well… only if she was polite and obedient. The second… the second I shoved and despised, humiliated and tormented her every time I was in a bad mood, and by the end i was always in a bad mood. Because of the ritual, I was in constant pain, jumping from euphoria to agony. But that wasn't an excuse, I was just taking it out on a helpless child. What annoyed me even more, the girls' friendship began to grow into something deeper. The loss of control infuriated me even more. I soon lost both of them.” And she told about the final stage of the war, though he was aware that now her story was getting murky because she had begun to speak in generalities knowing she couldn't reveal the truth. She had finally arrived at that great moment.

"Finally, the one I despised so much was in great danger, and I did the one really good thing in my life and sacrificed… something very precious to me. And then I left my home and found myself here.” She turned to Asindesa and touched her neck, disabling the

holographic masking so that the Hellknight could see her true face. Then she did something incredibly stupid. “My name is Shadow Weaver and I am a war criminal.” she said and looked down, waiting for a fair judgment. Asindesa di Vir touched her cheek tenderly to her surprise.

“We all deserve redemption. Everyone, you too Miss Daisy... Shadow Weaver.” She said and kissed her. She responded to the kiss of the Hellknight and they began to make love. She had never done that since the ritual, and she hadn't even known she was capable of it. It turned out that her body feels sexual arousal much stronger than before. Her body was hungry, so hungry, unsatiated. After an hour they finished and lay next to each other hugging, and the stars were the only witnesses of what happened between them.

“I have to go. Asindesa said tenderly touching her neck. I'm leaving in the morning on this last mission of mine and will be resigning when I return... I'm sick of this pointless war." We will settle in this castle and we will be together until the end. I love you Shadow Weaver. She kissed her and left.

She lay naked under the stars for half an hour until she got dressed and went to her solitude to think things over. It didn't bother her that she didn't encounter any of the servants. It wasn't until she saw the glow of the fire coming out of the fireplace in her solitary place that she realized what had happened.

“Welcome Calamity” she said as she stepped through the black wood door.

"How nice to hear own real name, don't you think, my dear Shadow Weaver?" her charge asked as she got up from the chair. She was dressed in modest, almost crude, travel clothes . She understood everything right away.

"I see you've arrived early, unannounced." she said with irony in her voice.

“And you, in my absence, organized a trip ... met new " friends" ... I'm so proud of you!”

The tone of her ward's voice made her clench her clawed hands, but she told her all too calmly.

“I'm sorry about your dress. This loss must have hurt you deeply.

Calamity smiled coldly.

“In fact, there's not much left of it, unfortunately. Many "brave" Frog people also died. It didn't have to happen. If only you'd give me a moment to explain…” She spoke in her sweet, gentle voice as if she were talking to a nice, though not very bright, friend.

“The situation was quite tense if you remember.” she drawled slowly.

“Ahh, yes, you had to save your fair knight. Too bad you don't like lizards. Sir Rakima regrets this immensely.” Calamity giggled .

“What did you do with him?” she asked cautiously, although she knew what answer she would get.

“I was a bit nervous about the ruined dress, but you know that you shouldn’t suppress negative emotions. But do not worry. His agony lasted only a minute, maybe a little longer. I'm glad the same didn't happen to your friend... I see a wonderful future ahead of her... But what kind of wonder it will be is up to you, my dear Shadow Weaver, because, as you know best, some of the wonders of the galaxy can break soul.” Calamity giggled .

"If you do her any harm, I swear by the darkness of my soul."

The pupil in her ward's eye melted, giving her eye a purple color. She smiled broadly. The fingers of her left hand turned into bony claws, and a bone blade slid out of her right forearm.

"What are you going to do to me, my dear?" Calamity began with an evil smile on her face, but she didn't let her finish, she only threw a stream of black fire towards the "girl", but she jumped aside and, kicking off the wall, jumped towards her tutor and tried to slash the dark sorceress with her living weapon . It created a shadowy tentacle that grabbed Calamity so that she fell and drove the bone weapon into the wooden floor. She summoned with a dark spell an ever-hungry blade woven from darkness, with which she cut Calamity, but Calamity rolled aside and grabbed the leg of the dark sorceress, knocking her to the floor. Despite this, she hacked blindly, hitting her ward, but she drew her to herself. It is unknown how the fight would go on, but then there was a voice that pierced their souls and minds.

“Enough.”

They immediately stopped fighting and rose to their feet. Leris came in, wearing the modest garb of a maid. Calamity sent her look full of pure hatred, but she realized that it was no longer Leris and fell to her knees.

-“Welcome, Creeping Chaos.” she said, feeling genuine horror. Calamity got down on one knee with some reluctance.

"First you fight each other in the face like children and force us to break the will of a mortal, which we don't like to do, and now you kneel before us as if we care." She sighed and continued. "Do you have any idea what's at stake here? Especially you Shadow Weaver... Our dear Shadow Weaver... You have to understand some things.” The Great Outer God explained in the voice of Leris . “You have far more to lose than any of our servants, so you'd better listen to me. Your journey to Kranor Rill was unforeseen, but in the end I'm glad you did it, because it saved my time, and I don’t need to demonstrate some things to you. These swamps and what the Krellans created in the old days may play a key role in the great and glorious enterprise of annihilating the First Ones and eradicating this plague from the surface of the galaxy. That's why we decided to use the technology of their former enemies... Details will be revealed to you in due course, don't worry. Just

know that the bloodstones will be rebuilt, albeit in a significantly cripled form. Leris said in a melodious voice .

“Asindessa ... please don't bring her into this..” she begged.

Leris shook her head sadly.

“Unfortunately, she was involved in this a long time ago. But fear not, for there is a chance that you will be together again... if you obey our orders.” they explained softly, and Calamity laughed.

“Ah yes... It's a bit of my doing. You see, your stories have taught me one thing. Those who have nothing to live for are a dangerous adversary, but also an unpredictable ally.” she giggled again, but Leris came over to her and pressed her hand against her cheeks.

“Do not think, our little Calamity , that you are so smart, because after all, you are a creature not much better than our dear sorceress, and you can even be so ... childish in your monstrosity. We know much about mortals and their souls, do not claim such insight. You extracted some information from your teacher, but did not you draw the right conclusions from it.” She released the aristocrat and turned to her. "We directed the void kraken to force Asindesa's ship to land on Carurystal... The rest was up to you, our dear Shadow Weaver, though we hoped for a similar result, for our little Calamity was right . Those who have nothing to live for and nothing to lose are unpredictable and uncontrollable. Lucky for us, you have Adora , Catra and Glimmer, you care about them. But they hate you, they are not your future, you wish they never met you again. But Asindesa di Vir is your future, your hope. And you mortals are at their strongest when you have something to live for and fight for your happiness. We don't even have to threaten you or even set your loved ones on our little Calamity. For you see, your dear Adora, your dearest daughters... They have destroyed not one, but two toys of the First Ones. They won't forget it, they won't forgive them, you can be sure of that. They shattered so many of their centuries-old plans. This cannot go without repercussions. They have another toy so perfect that even they fear it themselves. But they will not

hesitate to use it, even though the consequences disgust even us. There will be a hunger that cannot be satiated. Countless hosts. Pure will uncorrupted by the ego. But now we must leave you. This performance was very expensive for us. Unfortunately, I don't think Leris liked our company very much, but luckily you can clear your memory. She'll never be the same again, but it's better than nothing... Did you know she was fall inn love with you? - and then there was a shrill scream and the woman fell to her knees and cowered. She sighed and placed her hands on the unfortunate half-elf's head.

“I am so sorry darling” she whispered.

Wolf of War

Thanks to the bearings given by Dilayla , they found fleet relatively quickly and simply, but they didn't expect it to be a real armada. They saw at least five warships. Such large warships had only been seen in the Horde fleet. One of these ships was even bigger than anything the deranged tyrant had, except *Velvet Glove* . They stopped at a safe distance and broadcast what Dilayla thought was a galactic signal of friendly intentions. Soon, several smaller ships were sent their way and surrounded them.

“Who are you and for what purpose are you coming?” one pilot asked.

“I'm Jewelstar , and these are my sisters Tallstar and Starla. Here we come… we want to provide information about Horde Prime's Empire , or rather what's left of it.” her brother said.

“And Glory is also with us, our flashyowl.” Starla interjected. There was a silence that lasted for a good quarter of an hour. They were nervous and just scared. They didn't know if the commanders of this flotilla simply wanted to knock them down as a precaution. After all, they could be some crazy Prime loyalists who want to commit suicide attack or spies. Hell, she'd shoot herself in their place... Their ship was fast but poorly armed, for they preferred to rely on maneuverability and stealth. Their cloaking systems were pretty good too, and allowed them to hide from Horde ships if they didn't get too close, and from all the pirates, but she didn't know if those ships didn't have super-advanced scanners . They looked damn modern.

Finally, they heard the announcement. She jumped up and hit her head.

“This is Commander Reese, Right Hand of Lord Admiral Antares . I'm glad to meet the first Denizens of the Ravaged Zone we've

encountered... I mean, the Ravaged Zone is where you live... Although, actually, you're probably the inhabitants of this Prime's empire ... Actually it seems he's dead.... So actually, it's hard to say where you actually live. I'm sorry, this is the first time in my life that I'm doing this. I'm talking to people from a newly discovered part of the galaxy. Hello, inhabitants of the most cursed area of the galaxy. It's not implying you're cursed or anything like that. Anyway, on behalf of the Research and Exploration Fleet, I welcome you and invite you to… breakfast? Lunch! With Lord Admiral Antares . You have to dock aboard the battleship *Glory of the Fallen*... Ugh ... That's the biggest one... Then we'll see you there." And the message ended. They sat together in the cockpit for a few moments, stunned.

"It was… surprising." Jewlstar said slowly .

"To me, the commander sounded quite nice, certainly better than those madmen from Bellum." Starla said with a radiant smile.

"Well, we can certainly be sure that they are not preparing a trap for us. That sounded far too… awkward" Tallstar said thoughtfully.

Docking went quickly. Then some soldiers boarded them and searched them and their ship, though not very thoroughly. In their place, she would have had their stripped naked and interrogated for three hours. They hadn't even checked their necks, though on the other hand, they hadn't been seen much chipped since Prime's demise. Glory caused them the most consternation. They watched Starla's pet for several long moments before they stepped aside and made contact with captain, and then officer-looking one said.

"Unfortunately, it's best if your pet stays on your ship if it's not a problem. He could get hurt on the ship." he said in a polite and matter-of-fact tone that made her blink at hearing such polite words. They agreed and the Starla said goodbye to the Glory and boarded the warship.

The interior of the ship looked much different than they had expected, quite unlike the sterile ships of the Horde. Everything was illuminated with a warm light, the walls were covered with some kind of substance imitating wood. He even had a holographic painting on the wall of some predators howling on a hill.

“It's beautiful, isn't it? The Lord Admiral paid a lot of attention to interior finishing. *Glory of the Fallen* is our flagship and it needs to look right to represent the Fearless Armada… Now a Research and Exploration Fleet.” said the man, the same one they had heard earlier. in a gala uniform beaming with pride. He was well-built, had short-cropped hair, and looked somewhat like her brother. "I'm Commander Reese. Lord Admiral Antares is waiting for you. I will take you to him.” he said and motioned for them to follow him.

“I'm Jewelstar , and these are my sisters Tallstar and Starla. Lead us to your commander.” her brother said, shaking the officer's hand.

They walked for several minutes, passing numerous crew members going about their business.

“I'm sorry you had to wait so long, but there is confusion around here. It's knocked the entire fleet out of Drift all at once, and they're all having to reconfigure the drift drive and then re-sync it.” the commander explained.

“Drift?” she asked a bit confused.

“Drift, you know... a hidden. magical dimension where ships move. It has been discovered over three hundred years ago, almost all over the Galaxy at once. You don't know about him?” Commander Reese asked in surprise “Damn, he's younger than Jewlstar and he got that position." She thought and said.

“Until recently, until the fall of Horde Prime, magic was something that only exists in fairy tales.” She gave her siblings, especially Starla, a warning look not to blab anything about the Heart. The commander looked at them surprised.

“The galaxy is full of wonders beyond imagination. As a child myself, I did not expect to see what I have already seen and so much more to come.” he said cheerfully

"You joined the fleet looking for adventure?" Jewelstar asked curiously .

“No, my family farm was destroyed, only I survived. Lord Admiral saved me.” The commander became extremely serious and as if sad. They were silent for a moment, until her brother spoke thoughtfully.

“Our home has been devastated by the Horde. Only us and our uncle survived. Do you have someone similar? Those who sent us to you spoke of some Azlanti…. Was it them?” Jewelstar asked.

The commander winced and shook his head.

“The Azlanti are a bunch of imperialist speciesist bastards, but it wasn't them. They are rarely so brutal to humans. No, it was the Swarm. The galaxy's greatest scourge, worse than Azlanti, Corpse Fleet, Dominion of Black, or even the Great Old Ones.” The officer's voice was hard and grim. They looked at each other in disbelief. *There can't be that much evil in the universe. He just doesn't know Horde Prime. He does not understand that no one in the galaxy can match the wickedness of this monster. It's good that there isn't and won't be anyone in the entire galaxy that's nearly as bad.* Tallstar thought , and she was about to ask about the Swarm, but then they entered a large room where Lord Admiral Antares was already waiting for them ...

Lunch, breakfast, or whatever that meal was supposed to be was a huge surprise for them. First of all, it was much less formal and

lavish than expected. In fact, it was more like a pleasant meeting with friends than a solemn dinner with officials. Even on Etheria, etiquette was more closely watched, not to mention those pompous assholes from Eridani. They were served some roast meat, vegetable curry, some legume soup, biscuits, and green fruit mousse for dessert. The last one made them especially happy, the last time they ate something like this at Glimmer's dinner, almost a year ago. The food was simple and made from ready-made semi-finished products, but tasty. The only more exotic thing served was wine. Just the smell of him made her dizzy with the richness of the aroma.

"Please, drink it, it's elven wine from Castroval . It may not be as exquisite as their dream wine, but it is very good." said the Lord Admiral, personally pouring them the drink.

"I don't remember ever drinking wine. Horde Prime forbade alcohol from his subjects, except for a trace amount of wine, which he ordered to produce for himself." her brother replied and drank the glass with a smile.

"It is interesting, most dictators prefer their subjects to be drunk or drugged. Then they are less willing to rebel. No wonder he fell." said Asindesa di Vir, Lady of Blades.

"And the biggest bastards are teetotalers. Never trust people who never drink." said Lady Ka, reaching for the second bottle of wine and drinking it straight from the bottle.

Their hosts, however, surprised them much more than this simple and tasty meal. The Lord Admiral had a cybernetic eye similar to her brother's. He was an intimidating man, the first true space admiral they had ever seen. He exuded strength and confidence worthy of a true leader. However, she sensed a ferocity from it greater than that of the huge, semi-cybernetic wolf-like creature that sat next to his legs. There was also Asindesa di Vir, a woman who introduced herself as the Lady of Blades from the Order of the Eclipse. She was a powerfully built woman, a warrior who did not shy away from fighting on the front lines, as evidenced by the

acid scar on her face. She didn't know what this eclipse order was, but the woman came here in full armor that looked extremely menacing. She was somewhat like Adora , though much more intimidating and confident, as tough as the armor she was clad in. It also had its own armed forces. Her relationship with the Lord Admiral also seemed as cool as the blackness between the stars. However, they did not want to get into what was going on between them.

It was Lady Ka, however, who almost tore a startled exclamation from their throats. Dilayla had hinted to beware of her, which she had no doubts. judging by her nasty smile, but a mercenary forgot to mention one important detail. Bina and Lady Ka were identical, like twin sisters or… clones. The latter was a truly disturbing prospect. She and her brother somehow managed to control themselves, but Starla stared at her with her mouth open until she had to kick her in the ankle, but the twinkle in her one eye indicated that she suspected something. Well, you should have warned us.

“So you were freedom fighters?” the Lord Admiral asked after their first hunger had been appeased. Jewelstar smiled sadly.

“Yes, but rather unsuccessful. For almost fifteen years, we haven't had much success. We traveled from one planet attacked by Horde Prime to another, trying to join someone who could resist him, but no one was strong enough. We had to pay a high price for our struggle and stubbornness.” He pointed to himself and Tallstar . “Eventually all hope died in us and we became scavengers capable only of hiding from the enemy, until we met Adora and her friends from Etheria, who showed us that the fight was not lost yet. We returned to Icarus and resumed the fight there, and not long after Horde Prime was destroyed and now fighting its self-proclaimed successors, but we weren't very successful here either.”

After listening to her brother's story, the Lord Admiral nodded understandingly and spoke slowly.” Etheria... Our scientists observed the appearance of a mysterious planet in the center of

the Zone, where Lady Cala’s family is supposed to come from, you must have just met her, I presume?”

When he mentioned the name of a beautiful blonde woman, the Lady of the Blades flinched slightly, She raised an eyebrow, but did not comment on it, only replied to Antares .

“That, that's where we met her and the Skittermander’rs ship she rented.” will predetermine that they will stick to this version to fulfill Dilayla's request . “Etheria… as far as we know, this place has been hidden in another dimension for a thousand years. They didn't forget about magic therelike we did. Somehow a part of the Horde got there, and they faced it for decades until they were torn from their hiding place. Etherians are friendly to everyone, but they are also brave and combative. They defeated Horde Prime and restored peace to the universe, at least in partialy. she explained to their hosts, trying to tell them only as much as was necessary

“And they have She- Ra!” And princesses! Starla shouted suddenly, contrary to what she had previously agreed. Her sister drank half a bottle of wine, and she always had a bad head. She wanted to kick her leg and tell her to keep quiet and then redirect the conversation to another topic, but the Lord Admiral asked.

“She-Ra? Who is she?”

Datapad in her hands and began to talk in a joyful voice, showing the photos she had uploaded there.

“This is Adora. She turns into She- Ra , but when we took this picture, it was the first time we met, back in the days of Prime, she couldn't do that. And here is Adora as She-Ra.” As she spoke, Lady Ka, Commander Reese, and Lady of Blades approached her and looked over her shoulder at what she was showing. “This is Glimmer, the Queen of Etheria , and her boyfriend Bow. This is Entrapta. There are Scorpia and Perfuma ... It's the whole alliance of princesses. And this is Adora with her girlfriend Catra . They are about to get married, on the 5th anniversary of Horde Prime's

defeat . We will try to fly to their wedding. Oh, maybe the Lord Admiral will come too, there's going to be a great party!” Starla squeaked so much that her brother winced. However, Tallstar noticed something very strange. When Starla displayed the pictures of Catra and Adora, the Lord Admiral paled, and Madame Ka's face became indescribably furious.

“Perhaps I will cme.” The fleet commander said quietly and stood up. Commander Reese watched him with a concerned look, and Asindesa asked Jewelstar .

“You mentioned Horde Prime's heirs, what can you say about them?”

Her brother frowned thoughtfully.

“There are Horde Ultimate and Seven Heavenly Brothers. The first one is smarter. He considers himself a prophet of Horde Prime , but rules much more leniently and simply. He admits non-clones to power, his right-hand man is Saihe ... Drow woman. He is weaker, but more careful. The Seven Heavenly Brothers are true Horde Prime fanatics . They have a larger army and can create monsters, but they lose their strength in senseless attacks, even on Etheria. Most clones, however, wait entrenched in their strongholds and do not cooperate with the heirs or with each other.”

Then her brother briefly described some of the strongholds of these most hardened clones. The Lady of Blades listened to him, then asked in a somewhat timid voice.

"Are Lady Cala and her guardian, Miss Daisy, all right?"

Her brother nodded.

“Is that the elf sorceress? Yes, she's fine.”

Relief appeared on the face of the tough warrior. Then the Lord Admiral spoke.

“You will return to your ship. An officer will be dispatched to you shortly to give you all the information you need, and then an assignment will be worked out for you if you will swear allegiance to me. Now go away, everyone.” His voice was commanding and irresistible. They all followed his instructions, though the Lady of Blades did so with some reluctance. However, as they were leaving, the fleet commander asked one more thing.

"Starstone, does the name mean anything to you?"

Jewelstar shook his head.

“No, what is it.”

The Lord Admiral smiled slightly.

"Nothing, just the most powerful artifact in the galaxy."

They were now aboard the Honor, digesting their food and conversation. Commander Reese then gave them six more bottles of wine and told them to pack plenty of food.

“It's nice of the commander to give us such a gift.” Starla called out, definitely in the tone of someone already heavily drunk.

Jewelstar looked to the side, smiling sheepishly

“You have to admit, he's a very nice person.” he said with some shyness. Starla's eyes widened and she inhaled sharply.

“You *like* him so much, I see that!”” Youngest Star sibling’s giggled and her brother blushed.

“Starla, I think you've had enough of this wine.” Tallstar said, taking the bottle from her sister.

“You liked this mercenary too, you won't deny it!” Starla elbowed her sister in the side, and she replied with a sad smile

“It's not important, we'll never meet again anyway... Speaking of which, what do you think about our hosts?” she asked in a thoughtful voice.

"This could be a chance, a chance for all of us to finally do something big, but you don't look convinced?" her brother asked. She shook her head, still thoughtful.

"There were a few things I didn't like about it. First, they learned much more from us than we learned from them. And secondly, remember what Lady Ka said about non-drinking tyrants? The Lord Admiral didn't drink a drop.”

The Lord Admiral's ship was *Glory of the Fallen*. Lady Sorrowflame had her workshop aboard *Invincible*, the dumb knight had her order’s cruiser, and even that imbecile Commander Reese chose the spacecraft carrier *Unbroken* for himself . But Lady Ka didn't need a warship for herself. She didn't know anything about space battles, after all. When needed, she used a light, fast and nearly undetectable ship that could take a dozen thugs aboard, and on a daily basis she was aboard a freighter converted into a transport ship and barracks. He was called a Dumpster. Here were her subordinates. Now she was walking through a wide corridor and everyone who looked at her got out of her way, knowing full well what could end up getting in the way of a woman wearing a half mask... Almost everyone.

“Hey boss, why boss is so angry” the tall half-orc asked, smiling friendly at her. She also answered him with a smile as warm as the heart of winter and, grabbing a metal club from her belt, gave him a mighty blow to his leg until the bone came out, the half-orc screamed and she gave him another and another, with each strike there was a crackling sound broken bones. Finally, he was standing over a barely breathing man weighing more than twice her weight.

"Anyone else want to be nice to me and comfort me?" she screamed at the top of her voice. Everyone who was within earshot of her voice began to seek new occupations, as long as they were away from the Lord Admiral's left hand. Except one person.

“Are you better now? “Lady Sorrowflame asked as she stepped out of the shadows.

She thought and said.

“You know, not really. Comewith me to my cabin.”

They went to the cramped room where they had spent some quite pleasant moments together. But now she was too angry for that. She briefly told the ancient necrotechnics about the events of the dinner, and above all, about a certain photo.

“It turns everything upside down. All our plans.” She stabbed the knife into the bunk several times. Lady Sorrowflame smiled full, like a philosopher explaining basic truths to the little ones.

“Well, in life, you always have to be ready for big changes. I've been through more times than you can imagine.”

Lady Ka snorted hearing these words.

“It's easy for you to talk about it. You'll make it anywhere, no matter what happens.”

The flame-haired girl walked over to her and hugged her tenderly around the waist from behind.

“Look at it from the other side. Both cats will be within your reach, and the Lord Admiral only needs one.”

Icarus

It took an hour to fix the drift drive, and another hour to reconfigure the navigation. For a while, they considered jumping to Etheria immediately, made possible by the Starstone, said to be the most powerful artifact in the galaxy, but after consulting Captain Moonshadow, Bina decided to stick with the old plan. They will fly to Icarus and make the final decision on how they should get to Etheria. Bina already knew that after discovering that there was a Starstone on Etheria, she had lost any chance of persuading her kids to turn back from their path. This confirmed all the theories they had heard from the devil and demon cursed leech, let it dry to a crisp. She could see Itel's eyes light up at the thought of her greatest wish coming true... The greatest, except perhaps for her relationship with Eti to deepen, but now it was complicated because of Rosie.

On the other hand, she wasn't sure if she wanted to turn back. This Etheria seemed like a friendly and, most importantly, safe place. Here they may find solace from their eternal struggle with the whole world. Itel will learn to trust others, Lilka will not want to fight with everyone, Alatar will start to establish relationships with others outside their pack. Only Eti can be a problem, if her assumptions turn out to be true ... Although even then, if she really survived, it doesn't have to end badly, with a bit of luck nothing bad will happen, after all, even Eti is not that murderous machine, even though she is conditioned to try to kill “fallen sisters” as soon as she sees them... Okay, she does throw herself at random people's throats sometimes, but in this case even she should remember, it won't be a complete stranger... Maybe? Their fates certainly turned out so differently. But most importantly, they'll be far from that bastard Antares

This, however, is a problem of the future, albeit a very near one. For now, she had to get to Icarus and get information about Etheria. She also had the impression that her passengers were not very eager to reach their destination. It didn't surprise her that Rechiza, Arkan-tar, and Doctor Quin were suddenly very reserved.

They were scholars after all, albeit very unusual. However, Dilayla also seemed to be quite withdrawn and reluctant to talk, especially around Wrongdak. Did she resent him for what happened to the inhabitants of the monastery? She shouldn't hold a grudge against him for that, something similar had been done to her planet by Horde soldiers once, and she didn't mind befriending the white-skinned alien. But who could know what was really going on in the other person's head?

When the mercenary became gloomy, the grim elf became… well, drunk. The fact that she was drinking with Ireanis didn't reflect well on her. Only that the silver-haired elf got drunk happily, and the dark sorceress seemed to become more and more bitter and immersed in unpleasant memories. There was a strange resignation about her now, as if some strange fatalism had seized her. She respected this woman, though she sensed a very dark past in her , and would not want her to go downhill. But it wasn't up to her at all.

What surprised her the most was Lady Cala, both the combat prowess she had shown in the monastery and the determination she had shown on this journey. She never doubted that the stories about Etheria she had learned in the family archives were true, though everyone claimed otherwise. Well, it turned out that the truth was on her side. The young woman clearly deserved Rosie's adoration.

That's right, Rosie. The deaf girl practically became a crew member of her ship. She hardly spoke to the others of he companions, except for Dilayla and Miss Daisy. Bina seriously considered adopting Rosie. She was practically no trouble at all, polite and helpful, and she could fight better than most seasoned warriors she knew, and she knew the Shadows of Tarak, whom even the Vescas thought were mad. But where did an ordinary intern learn all this? The story Dilayla told her was puzzling, and she didn't like being surrounded by riddles, one Eti was enough for her. That's right Eti and Rosie. The growing bond between the girls was evident, and given the feline girl's preferences, her ward would expect something from Rosie, and did Rosie share such

preferences? And of course there was Itel. The elven solarian has experienced enough tragedy in her short life, and now she will be heartbroken even more. She should talk to her and comfort her somehow, but how, she didn't know what love was, she slept with men and women, like all Jantar clones, but she had never been in a relationship. But he has to do something

They jumped out of the Drift near Icarus. The planet had two continents, the smaller but better developed Icarus and the twice as large but poor Dedalus . Even from orbit you could see the difference, because it was night and the bigger brother was much less illuminated by city lights. Apparently, the larger continent was much more ravaged by the Horde. In addition, there were many islands here, and the temperature was above the Golarion average . They had learned so much from the Wrongdak and the spire they had hacked .

They waited until morning before deciding to make contact. She went to her communicator and sent a message.

“This is Deadly Sword of Burning Fury, please allow us to land.” She frowned a bit as she said the ship's name.

There was no response for a long time, so she assumed they didn't have a spacecraft arrival warning and management system here. Quite careless, but it's even better for them, because they will stay on the planet unofficially, which she and Captain Moonshadow were very keen on.

They contacted the pirate, trying to choose the most suitable place to land. They chose two old Horde landing sites, located close to each other on Dedalus , relatively close to the largest surviving city, Clytaimestra . There seemed to be a few towns here and some valley scorched by Horde Prime bombs . They all agreed that it was far enough away from major centers of power that no one would notice them, yet close enough to civilization that they could get information and buy some goods, although they still had plenty of supplies, even ice cream left over, though she's been giving double doses for the last few days. She already

had some idea of the cover they would assume once they reached Etheria. Only Alatar and Eti will moan.

Shaking as they entered the atmosphere, Alatar apologized embarrassed, though it wasn't his fault. The landing site was surrounded by a young forest, Mister Ilemshaw and Dragonkin taking great care not to burn it with their engines. As soon as they landed, she ordered the side exit open, and they all went outside. It was already afternoon, but still warm. She took a deep breath of fresh air. They were surrounded by the emerald, slightly shimmering green of the local plants. The surroundings looked so pleasant to me that Lilka assumed a fighting stance, Eti began to wag her tail, Alatar gripped the Datapad tightly , and Itel summoned the moonblade and cast hostile glances around. Her lovely children. Rosie, of course, looked around in amazement. She beamed and her joy spread to the others, even Itel relaxed a bit.

"Okay friends, let's do it like this, I, Arkan-tar, Rechiza and Lady Cala will go to the nearest Bar to ask about various things..." she was saying, but Eti interrupted her.

“I have an idea. Sell Stinka, maybe we'll get a bag of crisps. It's a profitable exchange.”

She gave her a reproachful look.

“You better watch out that I don't sell you. It is said that cat skin gloves are very fashionable everywhere in the galaxy. she asked her ward, who put her ears down.

“I don't see any reason to scold Miss Eti. She didn't offend me with her words, she even made me smile.” she said in a conciliatory tone, but the feline girl only blushed.

"Okay, now that we've all been nice to each other and apologized." Saying this, she looked eloquently at the feline ward. "Just don't kill anyone, don't set fire to anything, cause a riot, or do anything like last time?" she asked seriously.

Eti thought for a moment and said.

“Last time we saved Wrongdak and Emily, should we stop helping our fellow humans in need this time? All right, but then don't blame anyone when some beautiful woman gets eaten by a dragon! With mayonnaise. We will not save her!” the feline girl explained in an absolutely serious tone.

“These stories of dragons eating virgins are as offensive as they are ambiguous.” Alatar muttered, resentment in his voice.

“Oh, that's right Mr. Wrongdak.” she asked the colorfully dressed clone, who had been listening to the whole discussion with consternation. "I trust you and Emily and I believe you won't lie to me, will you watch the kids?" She asked smiling ingratiatingly. She preferred not to entrust this important matter to Ireanis and her new drinking buddy, and Mr. Ilemshaw's reach was limited. Wrongdak looked a little scared. She wasn't surprised.

Itel watched as Bina and the others drove off towards the city. She counted to a hundred, then turned to her friends.

"So, are we going to look around?" asked the elf, smiling happily. Wrongdak looked at her in amazement and disbelief.

"But, it's the complete opposite of what Bina asked you to do." said the clone incredulously. Emily chirped agreeing, but the solarian put on the most innocent smile she could and said.

“But we're going to do something completely different. We just want to explore the area to see if there's enough wood for a bonfire and where there's water to put it out.”

The alien immediately smiled happily.

“I like bonfires. When I lived with my Skittermander friends, we would often make bonfires... Several times they ended in fire, once when Alatar's relative had the flu, another time when Wydne

threw a power cell into the bonfire. Yes, you will definitely need water to extinguish the fire.” He nodded approvingly, though Emily was eyeing her skeptically with that purple eye of hers.

It was so easy it was shamefull she thought with satisfaction

“Oh, I'll make a bonfire! We'll bake sausages, we'll sing ancient orcish war songs like *Row, row, row your boat* and "*Hey Wyverns*. It will be fun.” cried Lila. Itel thought about explaining to the red-haired girl that it was a hoax, but changed her mind. Maybe they will make a bonfire in the evening, or Lilka will forget everything.

“It's Eti and... Rosie are coming with me to search the area, and Mr. Wrongdak, Lilka and Alatar... will take care of everything.” she said, trying to hide her sadness with a smile. Rosie jumped happily, and Eti nodded and asked.

“So when do we go?” asked the feline girl.

“Now!” said the elf and they set off together into the wilderness.

"But you'll agree that the crooked face was almost as bad as the Swarm." Eti said through the communicator. Itel snorted.

“What do you know about Swarm?”

“You know, quite a lot, as in any subject. After all, I am absolutely perfect, amazing and unique ...” Eti paused for a moment and added. “After all, you know what was done to me.” her friend said in a surprisingly serious and emotional voice. She couldn't remember ever hearing it from her. Something had changed in Eti, but Itel had no idea what. She only had the feeling that rainy days were coming, or worse, stormy days. Now it was a double problem because they had a mission ahead of them and they needed to focus and couldn't let anything distract them.

They were in a ghost town, the ruins of some peaceful settlement whose inhabitants had been displaced, or rather murdered by the

Horde. Now only the rain played among the ruins, but there was no one to hear it. She wanted to accidentally find a way to the nearest city, but she had the impression that she led her friends to a place they would never want to go again. First these ravaged planets, then the accursed monastery, and now the ruins where only the wind sang to the dead. It was weird here. She still had the feeling that someone was watching them, from among the shadows, some sinister, dark entities following them all the way through the town. She had suspicions whose doing it could be, could the lousy witch couldn't leave Eti alone for a moment. Or maybe it was just her paranoid delusions… Maybe seriously, because of these worries, she was already going insane?

Suddenly Rosie came over to her and hugged her tightly. She stiffened at first, but then relaxed and asked.

“Rosie, why did you do that?” she asked without breaking away from the hug.

Rosie shrugged, pulled away, and replied.

"Because you were sad and you looked like you needed someone to be close and show that they understood you too. This settlement… She made you so depressed, so I figured you needed someone to hug you. If this made you angry…”

She replied with a deep sigh.

“It's not that Rosie ... why are you always so nice to everyone, it would be easier for everyone if you were a mean bitch.”

Rosie turned her head and said.

“Not true. Do you remember the first time we met Eti? I hit her very hard then!”

There was such sincerity in the girl's light blue eyes that Itel realized that the situation was hopeless. She already knew why Eti

liked her so much, a deaf girl. Then they heard Eti calling them.

“Hey, I found something absolutely amazing here, come over immediately.”

Without waiting for further explanations, they ran to where, according to the datapad, the feline girl was supposed to be.

Hey, it's just a girl. Normal girl. You've seen the girls before, we're girls. You are a girl.” Itel said with suppressed resignation. She did not add that "you sleep with girls"

They were in a hut on the outskirts of an abandoned settlement. They stood by the window and watched some young, probably human, woman. She had blonde hair and fair skin. She was muscular and athletic. Pretty, though not as beautiful as Lady Cala. She was lying on the grass dreamily staring at the sky dotted with single clouds.

“Think Itel. We have Stinka ... And we all know how terrible she is and we all dream of throwing her off the ship.” the feline girl explained, as if explaining something obvious, but Rosie cut her off.

“But she is nice and good to everyone, only you have some prejudices against her.” The white-haired girl looked genuinely indignant

"Sparkle hand, if she's so great, then tell me why she tried to kill you." Eti said in a serious tone.

“She didn't try to kill me! I hurt her very badly” Rosie said

“If you don't believe me, ask Itel, she doesn't like any of you.” Eti pointed to the Solarian , who felt herself blush. “Eti, someday you'll get shot in the head for talking like that, Itel thought angrily.

Rosie looked at her with those big eyes that now looked like two blue lakes.

“I understand that you don't like me ..." the deaf girl apologized with a sense of guilt painted on her innocent face.” She covered her face with her hand and spoke slowly.

"It's not that I don't like you… it's just… it's just that." She tried to explain, but honestly, she didn't know what to say.

“Because it's about you and ... Where is Eti? “ Rosie suddenly asked, looking around in surprise. Itel swore in Elfi, because her friend of course took the opportunity and went away ... But where ... This puzzle solved itself as soon as she looked out the window ... Eti just stood behind the blond woman and asked.

“Hey blonde, there's this thing...”

She felt much better now. After a whole day and night away from others. Out here in the wild, no one wanted anything from her, no one demanded that she be She- Ra, the liberator and hero of the galaxy. Now she was just Adora again , just herself. The map Zei gave her was very accurate, and she learned a lot from Bow about surviving in the wild. Though Catra and Scorpia fared better. She spent the night in the tent, warming herself in the flames of the fire, on which she cooked the broth. Much less meat was eaten on Etheri, except in places like the Crimson Wastes and the Realms of Snow, and she enjoyed a delicate but hearty soup of lentils and bread. She slept so well that she overslept, so she decided to take a shortcut that she didn't like very much, but she didn't want to keep Scorpia and Perfuma waiting for her.

The journey through the abandoned town turned out not to be as depressing as she had expected. She heard that the inhabitants evacuated themselves and settled in the capital or other settlements ... Besides, she must have gotten used to such a sight. She'd seen so many ruins on Etheria and in former Prime's

Empire that she seemed numb... She knew she should worry about it, but instead she felt a surge of confidence. It was thanks to her and her friends that thousands of settlements were saved from a similar fate. She had no reason to feel guilty.

She stopped on a green hill and decided to rest for a while in the warm rays of the sun ... The sun was unknown on Etheria and many inhabitants of her planet treated it with a great deal of distrust. But not her and Catra. Sometimes they lay cuddled together, sometimes naked and warmed themselves in its gold rays. She missed her beloved. her girlfriend, soon to be wife. What she wouldn't give for Catra to be here with her… Suddenly she felt a gentle brush of her tail on her cheek. Full of irrational hope, he jumped to his feet and turned sharply. Instead, Catra saw someone else.

City of the Elder Things

Frosta got up as soon as the alarm clock beeped. It was still before dawn, the bright moons hadn't risen yet, and it was to chilly, at least for those born outside her realm. But she was tough and fearless, as mighty and fearsome as the glaciers that covered the mountain tops of her homeland. She was a Terrible Ice Bane. It was a really great name. One day he'll thank the Horde Ultymate for them ... right after, he'll punch him in that filthy face of his, if only for not calling her Princess Terrible Ice Bane!... And for everything else, of course.

She stretched herself, warmed up, and ran to make tea without waking anyone, though Melog began to twitch his ears listening. She could use Entrapta's plasma stove . She saw it last night, the inventor uses it and it was easy to paunch someone's face ... I guess she really wanted a fight, but who wouldn't in her place. She wanted to make tea quickly, before everyone woke up she would be waiting for them, hot and fragrant. So she turned all the knobs and turned on the fire…

As soon as she managed to escape, the flame shot up to the very sky ... and then it went out and the stove was smoking . The kettle has disappeared. Everyone jumped to their feet, preparing to repel the attack. Netosa surrounded the camp with a power grid, Catra stood by Melog with her claws out, ready to fight anyone stupid enough to mess with them. Even Lance and George stood up, armed with George's flashlight and ancient sword… Only Entrapta was unfazed. She walked over to the stove and studied it, or rather its remains, with fascination.

“What happened? How many are there, where are they hiding?” Netossa called, looking menacingly around.

“It's just me.” she said in a broken voice. “I didn't want something like this to happen. I think I broke the stove and the kettle

disappear. I'm very sorry.” She sat down with her arms wrapped around her knees and sniffled

Everyone calmed down, Netossa unsummoned net..

Catra walked over to her and, smiling softly, said.

"Nothing happened, the important thing is that you're okay." She sat down beside her and put her arm around her.

Netossa also approached her and knelt down.

“That's the way it is with modern technology. Greypaw once accidentally flew a Skimmer and only stopped when it hit a tree.” The Lady of Armoria added .

Entrapta, ignoring them, cried.

“It's fascinating. It was close to everything within a kilometer would disappear in a huge ball of plasma!” She clapped her hair and hands. Catra and Netossa looked at her with frowns, but the inventor did not notice.

“Well, we will eat a cold breakfast, and in the evening we will make a bonfire. We haven't done it for a long time.” said George, smiling at his memories.

“There will be no need, I have a second one in Alice. Ten minutes is enough, and if we hurry, we can do everything in five minutes.” Entrapta said, summoning her bot and began to pull out loaded equipment from it. There was horror in the eyes of the participants of the expedition.

“You know, Entrapta, why don't we give it a quarter of an hour and assemble it safely and carefully?' Catra asked cautiously.

"We'll save a whole five minutes, and the chance of an explosion will only increase by a dozen percent." The former lady of Drill was already assembling the machine.

“By a dozen or up to a dozen or so percent? Netossa asked, barely hiding the panic in her voice.

“Hmm.” Entrapta muttered and began to calculate something on the datapad

"You know, George, I think we have that portable tea warmer Bow gave us, I think it would be a good idea to take it out now." Lance said, and his husband nodded.

They prepared tea, on a strange disc, although it took quite a long time, because each portion had to be heated separately. She offered everyone a portion of butter with tea, because you have to eat it while it's still fresh, but everyone looked so strange ... as if she wanted to poison them? These inhabitants of warm countries could be really strange sometimes. Only Catra, after a moment's thought, asked for butter for tea and a double portion for sandwiches with crispbread and smoked fish.

“Well, i like butter, cheese and cream, all dairy products. They didn't have anything nearly as delicious in the Fright Zone.” Adora's girlfriend said. They gave the rest of the butter to Melog , who licked it off with relish. In this Kryat, knew what was good. Then they packed up and headed for the old guys' town or whatever. She knew enough about hiking in the mountains to know that the city was not as close as it seemed. She and Catra walked ahead, trying to find enemies to beat. She took a deep breath of the cold air, feeling the stress of the morning's accident melt away. Yes, she felt much better now. She was strong, scary and invincible! She was really happy. But Catra looked preoccupied.

“Catra, is something wrong?” she asked with sincere concern in her voice. The feline girl sighed heavily and said with a reassuring smile.

“No, absolutely nothing happened. I just miss Adora and get nervous before the wedding. Nothing more.” the Great Marshal assured her, but something in her voice made her not seem completely sincere, and Melog's eloquent look towards his friend and companion only confirmed her in this belief.

“You know, Catra, we're friends... - you can be honest with me and all.” she said smiling friendly, but the feline woman sighed heavily and asked.

“When we were in the ice palace, we saw that your chancellor was talking to a woman named Storm Heart, who comes from the Isles of Sorrow.” Catra sounded like she wanted to say something she didn't say, but she didn't understand what she meant.

“Yes, She visits us once every two months. She is a warrior and her mother is the leader of their kingdom… or whatever their country is. ” She said shrugging. Catra looked at her in amazement.

“Is their mother alive?” the Grand Marshal asked incredulously.

“Well ... yes, is there anything strange about it? She is Saihe, they live very long, sometimes over five hundred years.” She asked, growing more confused. Catra pursed her lips, turned to the blue sky, and spoke in a very low and grim voice.

“Storm Heart and her sister Midnight Mask are Shadow Weaver sisters. I've met both recently , and especially the second one, they seem to be little better than my ex-teacher.”

It took her a moment to fully understand what her friend was talking about, She had never spoken to that nasty sorcerer in her life, and she had only seen her a handful of times. From what she heard, she was very mean to Catra and Adora. Too bad no one had punched her in that nasty scarface when they could have. But when it all dawned on her, she asked with undisguised astonishment.

"Does that mean you have aunts…and grandmother?" she asked cheerfully, but Catra laughed very bitterly.

“Definitely not. I'd have to have a mother first, and Shadow Weaver didn't deserve to be called that. I don't have a family... by blood and I'm fine with that, Adora too.” There was a strange severity in the feline woman's voice.

"Yeah, but why are you asking me about this Storm Heart? She was nice to me and even gave me a spider that looks like it's made of jewels. He is beautiful!”

Catra sighed and said with concern in her voice.

“Listen... I don't like your chancellor talking behind your back to someone like this woman. Bad things can come of this.”

She looked at her friend in bewilderment.

“So what! I'm the princess of the elements, what can she do to me?” she exclaimed, trying to sound as confident as possible.

"Scorpia’s aunt once said that too." There was a warning note in Catry's voice. She responded with a snort.

“I'm only afraid of saber-toothed penguins.”

Catra laughed.

“Saber-toothed penguins? Does such a thing exist at all?” she asked with amusement in her voice.

"Yeah, they just haven't been heard of in a thousand years!" she explained.

“In a thousand years? We're not in danger of meeting them, are we?” Catra cheered up for some unknown reason.

“You know, She-Ra hasn't been heard of in a thousand years either, and then one of them showed up at my ball. she said with

a grin, but the feline woman replied with absolute seriousness.

“Good point.”

They watched in silence as a pillar of blue flame shot up into the sky, then faded, plunging the tundra back into darkness, until Lonnie spoke.

“What the hell is this?” Their girlfriend was clearly hunched over.

“Looks like we have company.” Scarlet said with interest, coming to the right of the general's companion.

“Oh, realy!” Lonnie replied, still annoyed, though until recently such a remark would have infuriated her. During this trip, a lot changed in the relationship between them.

"And was there supposed to be no one here but us?" he asked with concern in his voice. Lonnie gave him a sideways look.

" Kyle , you're starting again…" she began irritably.

“I'm not starting anything ...” he interrupted her “There wasn't supposed to be anyone here. And such things are not blown up by ordinary wanderers.” he said in a resigned tone, and Rogelio nodded at him.

The general's companion stared at him, blinking several times.

“Does it change anything? When we were going, we knew we might run into someone we would have to fight. Hell, when we launched the rebellion, we knew we'd have to force our way to victory.” She took a deep breath and added. “We are highly trained and have a new weapon that no one here knows about. We can beat anyone we meet.” Lonnie spoke firmly, pressing her lips together tightly.

“Almost everyone.” corrected their girlfriend.

Comrade General snorted.

“She is not on Etheria, as far as I know.”

“Supposedly.” he added, and Lonnie gritted her teeth.

“We can't act like She-Ra, Catra and the goddamn princesses are waiting around every corner. And even with bloody Frosta waiting for me in the fridge, it doesn't change the fact that our rebellion's goal is to take away their power, and we won't do it without a fight. –

He thought for a moment and said.

“You know, when you think about it, the prospect of Frosty waiting for me in the fridge is pretty scary. This is probably the scariest of the princesses.

Their girlfriend blinked a few times dumbfounded.

“What are you talking about, Kyle “she said in a hushed voice, then turned red and started screaming.

“You're doing it again. You want to talk me into letting you sit in Dryll and sit upside down again.”

He was about to say that wouldn't be such a bad idea, but Scarlet put her hand on Lonnie's shoulder and said, smiling at him and Rogelio condescendingly.

“Enough of such pointless discussions, Comrade General.” The sorcerer's voice had a barely perceptible tenderness in it, as if it contained a hidden promise. "We'll only know who or what we're dealing with when we see it for ourselves."

Lonnie took a deep breath, calming down a bit, and asked Scarlet.

“Do you know any magical ways to find out what's there?”

The sorcerer shook her head…

"Unfortunately, I'm not proficient in this kind of magic. Maybe if I had a little more time I could do something about it.”

Comrade General snorted contemptuously.

"If you were Shadow Weaver, you'd think of something." she said reproachfully, quite irrational in his opinion.

Scarlet smiled mysteriously and said

"But you only have me, and you only have to deal with me."

"I'm glad she's gone. To this day, I have nightmares about her walking the halls of Castle Crypto .” he said, swallowing loudly.

Scarlet looked at him askance, mysteriously and ominously.

“Indeed, she is gone, for now.” she said, and something in her voice sent shivers down his spine, and when Dr. Moors metallic voice rang out , he jumped in fright.

-“We can always send your little winged friend Imp . He has served Hordak well as a spy, and he will help you too.” said the brain in the cylinder.

He frowned. Over the last years, they have practically forgotten what position he occupied in Fright Zone Imp. Everyone liked him very much, but in the old days he was often feared, and the older members of the People's Rebellion still became wary of him. He was their scout, though he was less and less in that role these days.

“Yes, that sounds reasonable.” Scarlet said with a strange, dark joy in her voice

She helped Lance, who was supported from below by her husband, to the rock, and together they lifted George up. Entrapta, who had climbed the mountain on her own hair, and

Frosta, who had made herself an ice staircase, were waiting at the top. Netossa said she didn't want to strain her back and waited downstairs ready to intercept anyone who fell. Melog, in turn, guarded Netossa . He didn't like the place and was very nervous. Small obelisks with flattened surfaces stood at the entrance to the city. Thanks to this, they could see them in all their glory.

“It's old. It must be thousands of years old, you see, there is a road under the ice canopy, but on our side it's covered with a thick layer of earth. Given the meager vegetation here, it took thousands of years to” create such a thick layer of soil, so this city must have been here before the First Ones arrived!” Lance exclaimed in an excited voice.

"We can forget about myth of Etheria's original colonizers." She murmured with satisfaction. Of things related to the First Ones, only Adora didn't disgust her. Even She-Ra turned out to be something much older than that damned bunch of imperialists.

" Entrapta , could you redirect that satellite of yours here?" she asked the student. She nodded her head and said.

“That's what I'm doing, but first I have to listen to Susan . You know, she's a very meddlesome gossip girl.” Entrapta said, shaking her head in disbelief.

“This city was bigger than any on Etheria, except maybe the Fright Zone. Catra, you probably visited them the most of all of us, what is your opinion”? George asked.

“Some make the Fright Zone look like a sleepy town. Especially on Icarus.” she almost added that she had recently visited even greater ones in her sleep. She shivered. “But I don't know much about the ruins, even if the Fright Zone looked like it was about to fall apart at times. Ancient cities, this is your job.” She managed a warm smile.

Netossa created a energy net and they jumped into it. Then they headed for the city. She had to admit that a good night's sleep,

even if interrupted so abruptly, had significantly improved her mood. Life seemed much better to her now. She felt a familiar tingle of excitement before a new adventure. Full of impatience, curiosity about what the coming hours will bring. She wished Adora, Bow , and Glimmer were here , but maybe they'd be back soon. They won't explore them all at once, and the ruins won't escape... she guess...

Frosta was also radiant with enthusiasm, despite their recent conversation. She was worried about the youngest of the princesses. She didn't seem to care what her chancellor was doing behind her back, and if the Shadow Weaver family was half as mean and calculating as a dark sorceress, that could cause problems. She approached Netossly anxiously she said in a hushed voice.

“Hey Netossa, we need to talk about Frosta” and quickly summarized her concerns about visits from officials from the Isles of Sorrow. The Lady of Armoria frowned deeply.

“You're right, it's disturbing.” The white-haired woman sighed. “It used to be the Star sisters who were supposed to look after her and protect her, but you saw how Halo became, and Neutrino was always the dark and mean one. She was feared by everyone when she was young, but she never joined the rebellion.”

She shuddered and spoke in a grim voice.

"If Neutrino is worse than Halo, I'd tear her throat out. We need to talk to Glimmer after we're married and look into the whole thing. Maybe we'll even go to the Isles of Sorrow. I would love to meet Shadow Weaver's mother, I wonder if she will call me her daughter's ward. Or maybe she'll consider me a granddaughter.”

They listened to the voices coming from Imp's mouth . One he hardly recognized, this one probably belonged to Netossa . And the other he knew from early childhood.

"You know, I've almost forgotten what Catra's voice sounds like when she's not yelling at anyone or threatening anyone. It even sounds nice, don't you think, Lonnie?" he asked the general's companion. Lonnie snorted.

"She could always be polite and accommodating when she wanted to. We can not believe her." she said with contempt in her voice.

"Your... Our relationship with the great Marshal is not as important as what we intend to do with her presence here. We all know he's a tough opponent." Scarlet said in a gentle and careful voice, just the kind not to make Lonnie angry… about Scarlet, she was beginning to complicate their relationship. Though Lonnie tried to hide it, though he didn't understand why, he and Rogelio could easily see that the bond between the sorcerer and the general's companion had grown stronger. It didn't bother them, they were never jealous, and if either of them wanted to establish some kind of additional relationship, they accepted it, although they thought it would be nice if they were informed, but they both understood that it was not easy for Lonnie ... he just felt that Scarlet was different. He knew her from the old days, better than most. He remembered that she was a very laid-back girl who chattered about nonsense all the time. Their new Scarlet was calculating, cunning, and absolutely focused. Plus, she was a sorcerer, though she hadn't shown any talent in that direction before. Actually, come to think of it, it had something of a Shadow Weaver about it, which was a scary thought.

"She's alone, without She-Ra and Glimmer, and we've known her weaknesses since we were children." said Comrade General in a firm voice.

"But did you know it works both ways? Besides, as far as I remember, she was usually the one who beat you in training. And that's when she was alone, and from what I understand it's Netossa and Frosta here, and did I say that I'm afraid of Frosta?"

" Kyle is right, fighting Catra was never our goal. Maybe it would be wiser if we passed each other. And then we'll search the city

ourselves, perhaps even following in their footsteps.” Scarlet said, supporting him to his surprise. Lonnie thought for a few moments, then spoke through clenched teeth.

“They won't hide and run again. All my life I had kept my head low, submissive and humble, while pet Shadow Weaver was ready to set the whole world on fire for her ambition and wounded pride. No, I won't humble myself again. Now it's time for me to roll the dice, and I will, even if only dragon eyes fall out.” she mentioned the result of two ones on the dice, symbolizing both bad luck and good fortune, depending on the context.

From the inside, the city was much larger than it appeared from a distance, and also much more alien. The buildings were made of a strange substance that looked like crystallized clay up close. But she was tough, and even her claws couldn't scratch their surface.

Maybe you forgot to sharpen them? Frost asked, but then she hit the stone and left scratches on it.

“Sometimes I forget how sharp they are. It's surprising that Greypaw 's are not as sharp!” Netossa exclaimed

She smiled grimly.

"Mine are… special," she said, wondering whether or not to tell them about her “discovery.

“Catra's claws contain titanium, tungsten. I tested them in the Fright Zone when… Entrapta began , but unexpectedly bit her tongue and changed the subject pointing to the mounds. "It's unknown, but the scan shows it contains organic elements, as if someone had forced the snail to produce slime as hard as diamond when it solidifies. Oh, biotechnology is really amazing!” shouted the inventor so effectively changing the subject that she probably forgot what she was talking about.

The city was surprisingly modest looking. Or maybe more gray? Lance and Entrapta theorized that the creatures inhabiting this place simply perceived the world differently and perhaps for them this city was beautiful and fabled. They didn't see much technical equipment here, here and there they saw places where there might have been some equipment but it had been dismantled or… completely decayed, Entrapta said. The road was hard, made of a similar substance as the buildings, but there were no sidewalks anywhere, as if foot traffic didn't exist.

They discovered the truth when they came to a great cavern exposed by the sliding people. It was dark here, so although they had flashlights and chemical lighting, she was their guide. There was a strange smell everywhere, leaving a bitter-sweet taste in her mouth. Melog didn't like it here. He put his ears down. Everywhere they cut small indentations that arranged them in groups. Lance George finally came to the conclusion that there must be some subtitles.

We don't know him. We expected them to use Aklo here” Lance said.

“Aklo?” She asked because she had a feeling she had heard the name somewhere before.

"It's a language spoken by many of the older races." said George, and after a moment added, " Lightspinner has created the best translation of this language."

“That explained a lot.”

Finally, they reached a place that explained the mystery of this place a bit. It was a great chamber, capable of holding thousands of beings. And it was covered with countless paintings. They were white in many different shades. Here, for the first time, they saw the inhabitants of the city, or at least their images. They were tall and elongated conical creatures with *Heads* topped with tentacles. They had great webbed wings and five legs. She had never seen anything so strange.

“They're ugly.” Netossa said, grimacing in disgust.

“We shouldn't judge others by their appearance.” Frosta said, and everyone agreed with her. Subsequent drawings depicted meetings of the city's inhabitants with equally strange creatures that looked like winged beetles. They also saw a drawing of a giant with an octopus head. Unimaginable evil emanated from him.

"Isn't it Great Cthulhu from the Book of Dead Names?" George asked.

“Didn't we use this book as a support for the leg of the table, you know, the marble one? Lance said, rubbing his beard.

“Yes, we didn't want the boys to be scared by these terrible illustrations. This table is really heavy. " There was concern in Georg's voice.

Yeah, I guess we'll have to invite the sons to help us lift it. Lance added with absolute seriousness.

“All of them. It's a really heavy table after all.” George stated, and Lance added.

“And we'll take care of our grandchildren.” Both men bared their teeth in a sly smile. He and Melog exchanged significant glances.

“Slap me on the head if I start acting like a grandma.” she said to her companion. Then they looked at the drawings again. They saw that the inhabitants of the city had made servants for themselves. They were formless creatures with many eyes and tentacles. They built the city and many other structures. They were controlled by the city's rulers with strange staffs that emitted multicolored light.

“You were right, they are nasty bastards. They have enslaved the multi-eyed monsters!” Frost exclaimed indignantly.

Then they heard the flapping of wings that sounded oddly familiar to her.

"Hey Catra," Lonnie's voice said.

Unexpected Encounters.

“Hey blonde, there's a thing ...” said strange person. She was dressed all over with a brown cloak, a mask over her face, and her eyes were shaved. Her right hand was made of metal, and more importantly, it was covered in symbols she knew all too well.

"But who are you?” she asked, trying to take stock of the situation.

“You grew up in a police state, that you ask everyone about the most personal and private matters?” said the other person, waving a metal hand in front of her nose.

"Actually, yes... Could you tell me who you are, because... it's starting to get weird." she said with a mix of confusion and amusement. She liked that person.

“I'm Eti, who else would I be?” Eti stated as if explaining something absolutely obvious Then two other figures came out of the building half hidden among the trees. One was a white-haired human girl with almond-shaped, blue eyes who smiled kindly at her. The second was a green-haired Saihe girl with a body covered in tattoos. To her surprise, Saihe summoned a spectral blue blade and glared at her menacingly. They were both the same age she was when she found the sword...

“Hi, I'm Rosie and this is Itel. Our friend Eti you have already… met.” She began to speak, waving her hands, and the voice from the gloves explained what she was showing. Entrapta would like that. Device.

“Yes, since you already know our identity, and I must point out that we don't know anything about you, let's get down to business. You see, there's one blonde on our ship. Stupid, mean, and on top of that, it stinks horribly. We absolutely all have

enough of her, but our captain insisted on dragging her along, though by the devils and demons, I don't know why, but you're blond too, so we'll just swap one blond for another, quietly, and no one will notice the difference. When the truth comes out, we will be far in space and our captain, Bina, when she meets you, she will understand that she made a great exchange and thank us for that" said the girl called Eti, gesticulating fiercely with her hand and tail, although her voice was surprisingly calm. The other girls looked at Eti in embarrassment. She smiled because the whole story was funny and cheered her up.

"Unfortunately, I can't go with you. My friends are waiting for me in a nearby town, and then I have to go back to my planet for my own and my friend's wedding … My name is Adora, by the way." she said friendly, carefully checking to see if they recognized her name. Saihe , however, only murmured "mommy's girl", Eti exclaimed, raising her finger in a gesture of triumph.

"And ours is called Stinka. You see? Even her name stinks. it's a sign from fate and all the cool gods that we need to make this swap!"

Rosie looked at her indignantly and said.

"Her name is not Stinka, but Lady Cala Grayskull of Carurystal."

"Grayskull?" she asked incredulously. After all, Mara and her squad had lived and died a thousand years ago, if not more. Could it be that someone has escaped the Superiors and Horde Prime's watchful eyes ?

"Yes, Grayskull She is an aristocrat from a very old and respected family." Rosie said.

"Could you tell me about her?" she asked, trying to hide her curiosity. The deaf girl beamed, but Eti snorted contemptuously and Saihe looked at her suspiciously.

"Lady Cala has blonde hair and blue eyes like you, but she's taller and slender than you, but incredibly strong. She is also very

Intelligent, beautiful and fights great. And her hair is absolutely gorgeous.”

“Hair you say?” She instinctively touched her own.

The white haired girl nodded.

“Yes, they look like ribbons of gold glistening in the sun.” Rosie's eyes shone as she talked about that woman. She saw a similar glow when people talked about her, and she hated it. It reminded her too much of the look of the clones when Horde Prime was mentioned. ord

“You know what? I would love to meet Lady Cala . Will you take me to her?” she asked with undisguised enthusiasm. She really wanted to see this Lady Cala , and then there was this strange prosthetic of masked girl

"I don't know why you want to meet her, because you'll get terrible disease from her! But okay, she should be just like our captain in the nearest town. You can take us there if you know where it is. And so we had to go there.”

“We had?” Rosie asked suspiciously.

“Of course!” exclaimed the other girls at the same time.

She smiled happily and said.

“My friends Scorpia and Perfume are there too, so you'll meet them too!"

-“Let's go.“ Eti shouted and ran dodging through the trees.

She glanced behind her as she felt the shadow move behind her, but she didn't deviate, so she followed the other girls.

She moved away from the flat, circular obsidian tabletop she used to watch others through her shadows and tried to steady her breathing. She decided to stay on the ship because she wasn't feeling well, but then Eti and Rosie left the ship. After everything that had happened lately, she was afraid to let them go, so she decided to follow them with her shadows, as she often did in the Fright Zone… Itel seemed to suspect something, but said nothing to the others. And then they met Adora . She couldn't quite believe in such a twist of Fate. Of all the countless beings, they must have encountered her! Whether the hand of Creeping Chaos was involved, she didn't know. Lately she had begun to see their tentacles everywhere... Certainly their machinations ran much deeper than Calamity had told her , though she was beginning to suspect that her beautiful and evil ward's knowledge did not go as far as she liked to believe. What was certain was that Nyarlathotep themselves had concealed much from her. They couldn't help but know that there was a Starstone on Etheria.

Starstone. The most powerful artifact in the galaxy. The heart of Absalom Station. An item that allows you to use the Drift Drive. Relic of the Lost Golarion that had the power to turn mortals into gods. *A Is that what you are She-Ra? A goddess clothed in mortal flesh? What have you done to Adora…and Catra! Do you know, Adora, what path you have entered. Do you, Catra, know what fate may await your beloved?* she thought many times in the last hours. The existence of a second Starstone on Etheria, her planet, explained a lot, including why the First Ones decided to build a Heart in this place. But it wasn't the presence of the ancient artifact that terrified her so much, but who it might attract.

In her life, she met many monsters, even served a few. She couldn't hide the fact that she herself was one of them. But Lord Admiral Antares was a monstrosity of a different kind. When she saw him, all she saw was a tough military man, someone like the hapless Sir Rakima , and at worst like her sister Storm Heart. And he was a son of a bitch capable of bombing his own planet with nuclear warheads. He was as evil as Horde Prime, but was devoid of his madness and megalomaniac. He was ruthless and calculating, but he was able to hide his meanness behind a mask

of nobility . He was a wolf in sheep's clothing, although perhaps a better description would be a wolf in dog's clothing, given the image he was trying to create. Even Calamity , in all her perverse sadism, deigned to regard Lord Antares as a threat. Of course, it also resulted from pragmatism, after all, this ruthless and cruel man could stand in the way of the Creeping Chaos' plans. She was grateful for that, though she would have gladly let Eti throw her out the airlock if she could.

She sipped from a glass of the vile moonshine Ireanis made. She's been drinking a lot lately. More than Carurystal. She told herself it was because she thought better then, that she had the best ideas when she was drunk. She knew she was just a mean drunk, not much less pathetic than Ireanis. She looked at the silver-haired elf, who was sitting on a stool, snoring. Even she hid something more, which she discovered during the fight in the monastery. He just has to find a way to get it out of her. She's always been good at it. But now she was back at the table to go back to following Adora, one of the daughters she had lost.

He laughed, stroking Toshi's head, who began to squeal happily. It was supposed to be safe on this planet, so Mr. Ilemshaw decided it was okay to let the pet off the ship. The electric fox began to romp happily around the area. Emily followed him in fascination, and he entertained by throwing nuts to Toshi , which he caught in the air. It was pleasant to him, and for this reason he agreed that they should go away from the ship. Only, they must have gone further than he expected, because judging by the signs on the asphalt road they were walking on, they were quite close to the town where Bina and Lady Cala had gone. All the time Lilka tried to hitchhike, although her methods were probably not the best.

" In the name of the Horde halt!" The red-haired girl screamed, brandishing a flaming axe. The half-rusted car accelerated rapidly.

"I'm not sure it's a good idea to mention the Horde on this planet." he said carefully and seeing the girl's eyes he added.

“Even the good orcish one.”

Alatar sighed and said.

“Seeing a screaming person brandishing an ax makes them not listen anyway.”

He nodded his head and added.

“I won't catch him either. The people of Icarus have lost a great deal because of my brethren, and they may be reluctant to take people like me into a vehicle… And you, Alatar…”

The technomancer sighed.

“Even on the Pact Worlds, my species is quite rare. Probably no one here has heard of us, or worse, they will take me for a real dragon.”

He had heard of dragons on Etheria . The previous She-Ra was said to have ridden a real dragon, but generally they were mistaken for creatures from fairy tales and myths. Then it turned out that they are really alive, they even run their own corporations. He would love to meet one to tell Adora about it, though Swiftwind would probably be sad.

“Maybe Emily and Toshi will catch a hitch!” Lila exclaimed loudly. Bot and Lis looked at her in surprise.

“No... We won't fit in most vehicles anyway.” Dragonkin said, looking meaningfully at himself.

“Don't worry, Emily is not ashamed of her size.” he tried to console Alatar. Emily nodded.

They walked among green meadows and groves full of young trees. It was so green here. It was good to be among the living vegetation after being on a spaceship for so long. He did not count the monastery, because it was a depressing place.

“Shouldn't everything here be burned to the ground?” Alatar asked in surprise.

“You must have looked wrong. On map” said Lilka, equally delighted with the view that spread around them. They came to a small town, or maybe a village, he didn't know. It looked half abandoned, built around the intersection. In the distance he could see faint mountains with flattened peaks. There was a gathering place in the center of the settlement.

“Festival! There will be cotton candy. We orcs love cotton candy!” Lila exclaimed happily. They quickened their pace and reached the center of the settlement. He could see several guards around him discreetly watching them solemnly. A crowd of Icarus residents, mostly children, gathered around a large fountain located at the intersection . He also saw two women who made his heart skip a beat.

“Scorpia! Perfuma! It's me, Wrong Hordak.” he exclaimed happily and looked at Alatar to explain to him who his friends were, but Dragonkin folded his wings in fear.

“Hold Lika!” he called…. The red-haired girl gripped the ax tightly and roared.

"In the name of the Horde, I command you to leave these children and this pretty lady alone the spawn of the Swarm!"

“And up to the sky.” she called to the children hanging on her pincers, lifting them high in the air. The children laughed loudly, and their joy rang in her ears. She liked children, perhaps because she didn't have a childhood herself, though she'd thought otherwise for most of her life. She hardly remembered her mothers, they died when she was very small, and even then they didn't have much time for her because they were fighting her grandfather's war. Then ... it's hard to say who took care of her. At first it was Shadow Weaver, until she found out she couldn't bond

with black garnet, then she lost all interest in her. She didn't understand then how lucky she was, she just cried all day. After that, Cobalt, Grizol , and others like Doctor Moors , or even Hordak looked after her, but until Catra and Entrapta met, she had no one close to her. And now she was married. She was starting to think about the children. She just needed to talk to Perfume about it , but when she looked at her wife, who was looking at her with a tired but also dreamy smile, she knew what the answer would be.

Suddenly she heard a call and, having first placed the children carefully on the ground, she turned around smiling.

"Wrong Hordak!" She exclaimed happily seeing a friend she hadn't seen in years. He was dressed differently now, very… colorful… beautiful! And there was Emily, just as colorful. He also found new friends. A large, silver-scaled lizard with wings, completely unlike Rogelio and the other lizards of Etheria, and a short but beefy girl with red hair braided in pigtails and a body covered in strange tattoos. She was clutching a really huge axe. She looked like she was angry or scared, it was hard to tell.

"In the name of the Horde, I command you to leave these children and this pretty lady alone the spawn of the Swarm!" The girl screamed and started running with a roar towards them. Lizard called to hold Lilka. He grabbed her right arm, tried to stop her, but she only slowed down. Wrongdak jumped to her legs after a while and tried to stop her, but the girl continued to walk relentlessly, dragging both of them with her. She was really strong. Perfume got up and stood beside her.

"Girl, Lllko, the Horde no longer exists." said Princess of Plumeria and covered the children and other civilians with a wall of plants. Wrong Hordak began to shake his head hearing her words, and the girl screamed again.

"It' not true! We orcs fight for honor and good while at least one of us lives! – and she sped up. She had no idea if there were werks , but she probably had to stop the girl from hurting herself

and others. She wanted to use thunderbolts, but she guess that would be a bit too brutal. She could also sting her, but she'd save that for last if she had no other choice. So she just grabbed the handle of the axe. She immobilized the weapon, and the redhead made a surprised face, but pursed her lips and, not letting go of the weapon, tried to kick it heavy with her boots.

“Hey girl! We won't do anything to you.” She hit her ankle hard and then let go. The strange lizard released her too and pulled out some device and did what appeared to be casting a spell and then the shaft of the weapon was coated with a slippery substance and the ax slipped from the redhead's hand. The other one just growled and wanted to jump on her with her fists, but then Perfuma summoned plants that entangled Lilka. The girl tried to break free from the green bonds, and when she failed, she screamed.

“If you try to lay eggs in me, I will bite.”

They both blinked and looked at each other in amazement.

"But why would we lay eggs in you?" Perfume asked in surprise .

“You vile minions of the Swarm always do that.” Lilka screamed. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw her wife flinch at the word Hive. Wrong Hordak stood up and placed a hand on her shoulder.

“These are my friends, Princess Scorpia and Princess Perfume.” he explained to the girl, and the strange lizard added.

"But Lady...Princess Scorpia only has a few insect things. Remeber Shirens or Troxes , and you're not afraid of Shirens, are you?" He spoke to her in a soft and calm voice.

The girl pulled and said

“Shiren are stupid. Eti says so.” Lilka said in a sad voice. By now she had calmed down and the Perfuma had untangled from the plants. Then the guards began to come down, looking threateningly at the newcomers, especially at the Wrong Hordak .

"Nothing happened, it was just a small quarrel, a simple misunderstanding..." She tried to reassure the soldiers, because in fact nothing had happened. The soldiers hesitantly put down their weapons, but continued to eye the three newcomers suspiciously. The more she calmed down, the smaller and more vulnerable she seemed.

“I am really sorry. I didn't want to do anything to anyone. We orcs don't usually do things like that.” She burst into tears as she said this. She knelt beside her and hugged her, and then the girl burst into tears. Perfuma sat next to her and gently stroked the girl's head. However, she had the impression that her wife was worried about something.

“These are my friends. They saved me and Emily from a terrible fate…" Wrong Hordak said and Emily nodded.

“Are you from Kesler?” Perfuma asked suddenly. The lizard looked at her surprised. Then he added heartbreaking sadness.

“Not any more. Kesler is no more.”

“I don't like this blonde.” said Itel, staring at the back of Adora , who was marching briskly in front of them .

"You never like anyone, especially pretty girls who are nice to me." Eti replied. The Solarian gave her an indignant look, but spoke in a conspiratorial tone

“She's a random chick who was hanging around in the wild looking for who knows who or what, then she said something about her friends, and now she suddenly wanted to meet Lady Cala”

“Okay, that last one is weird, but that's because Rossie faked Stinka image.” when she said that, the deaf girl huffed. She did it in a really cute way. "But as soon as she meets her, she and her gang will rub her up."

“Gang?” both asked incredulously.

“Can't you see she's a gang member? Adora, Scorpia, Perfuma , no one is called that. They're gangster nicknames. He's probably going on a job with them. Not only is she pretty and athletic, but she also has an honest profession. I like her. Only that hair fetish Is weird.” she said with more commitment than usual. Lately she's been feeling more... just feeling...

“That makes sense.” Itel said frowning, but Rosie just rolled her eyes.

“You're terrible. We met a very nice woman, and you suspect her of gods know what.” she said in agitation.

“You like even Lady Cala , you'll see for yourself.” Eti said and ran to Adora.

“Hey blonde, tell me about your buddies.” she asked the blonde-haired woman, who smiled softly.

“Scorpia is a huge and powerful warrior, we grew up in the same place, although we met very late ... our first meeting was not the best. But she has a good heart and loves to cuddle, she's great at it. Her wife Perfuma quite strange, Very spiritual and tender. But don't be fooled by appearances. She becomes a real awesome in combat. And he loves plants, all of them, even cacti.” Adora told them.

“Yeah.” said Eti and doing a dance pirouette and said to her friends and began to explain in a hushed voice. “Have you heard? This Scorpia is thug. They grew up in the same neighborhood, but they were in rival gangs until she changed sides. This Perfuma is a botanist who grows funny plants for commodity, of those who will taste some of their herbs, but in battle she takes a drug that turns her into a battle monster.”

Rosie looked at her skeptically.

“She told it completely differently.” said the white-haired girl.

“Because I can read between the lines.” Eti said in the most scholarly tone she could manage.

“Probably between your imaginations.” Rosie said, crossing her arms over her chest.

They were taking back roads, or rather paths, and she felt torn, as if her soul had been stretched between two rocks. A rock of awe and a rock of despair. For her, both were the same and intertwined so tightly that they became inseparable. She balanced between Stormy and Rainy Days, and whichever will prevail, she and the others would suffer. Another reason to find something to do, and taking this cool blonde to Odora was as good as anything…

Itel came up to her and said.

“Someone's following us. Some shadows.”

She sighed.

“It's Grimmy. It's good that she does.” Solarian replied .

“But why? There's something wrong with her.” Itel said looking at her like she was crazy.

"She saved my life twice, Rosie's and Alatar's once, though she could play dumb. I want her to keep an eye on us and come to our aid.” She looked hard at her friend. They moved on, they were already reaching some settlement, from where came the increased noise, which she sensed with her sensitive hearing. Could be interesting, would love to see what's going on there.

She didn't know why she felt so strange. Maybe because of that fight in the monastery. The whole trip had been pointless, she'd known it all along, everyone knew it. They had no chance to save anyone, it was known from the beginning that they were all dead, murdered by a monster as evil as Horde prome or Lord Admiral… or herself.

But, most likely, everything was due to her dream, the meeting with Other One. She sincerely hoped it was just a product of her warped subconscious. Or at worst, an angry and tormented ghost. She came to punish her for a life he never knew. Otherwise, it would mean that... she was the one who was robbed of her life. She clenched her fist full of impotent rage.

“Wrong Hordak?!” Adora exclaimed happily.

“You know Wrongdak?” she asked, seeing a white-skinned alien from a distance, as well as Lilka and Alatar, and Emily and Toshi. This didn't surprise her, after all, they had arranged to get the Wrongdak off the ship somehow and go to the city, where they would meet together… The first part of their assignment had gone well, but the second had gone… worse. Why did they make such a crowd around them? Had Wrongdak messed something up? And she was already starting to like him!

And then she saw two women. One was huge, white-haired, wearing a black and white jacket. Most importantly, it had pincers and a scorpion tail. The second was tall and blonde, though much smaller than the first. She had flowers in her hair and wore a green dress.

“Perfuma and Scorpia?” she said under her breath. She had imagined them differently.

Wrongdak gave Adora a tight hug while Emily brushed against the scorpion woman who, along with her companion, moved towards them. Just like the soldiers.

“It's so good to see you. A lot must have happened while I was gone. he said sadly.

“You do not even know. You've changed a lot too. You don't call me brother anymore.” Adora said.

“Because calling Vesk brothers can end very badly. But I met many new friends. Adora, Scorpia, Perfuma, Meet Eti, Itel, Lilka,

Alatar and Rosie. And I present to you Princesses Scorpia and Perfuma, and Adora , Princess of Power, She- Ra'a of Etheria

Mysteries hidden in the dark

“You disgusting freaks, you won't hypnotize us like those poor monsters.” she screamed into the darkness above them, and threw a cloud of icicles around them. There was a frightened squeak, not very scary and quite harmless sounding.

- Frosta, calm down, he's not a Inhabitant of the City, he's an Imp, I remember him from the Fright Zone. Hordak created him from his DNA. But he spoke in Lonnie's voice,” Catra said in a worried voice.

“Lonnie? Isn't that your horde buddy. she asked her friend.” She remembered her from visiting the Fright Zone when they freed Adora , and she remembered her helping Catra and Scorpia when Glimmer was kidnapped…it was mean, but then she became friends with Scorpia and Catra. She can also be friends with Lonnie.

"The problem is that Lonnie has joined, or rather founded, a People’s Rebellion and wants to send me to Beast Island and take power from the princesses. Including you.” said the feline woman, looking around. The cave was huge and the imp 's voice echoed everywhere, so that it was impossible to determine where it was.

“Hey Lonnie, come over here!” she shouted at the top of her voice, and her scream echoed through the ruins until dust rained down from the ceiling.

“The ice has obviously breached the ceiling over the millennia.” Lance said, but then Entrapta called out

“Imp! Great to have you here Imp ! Long time no see! I never got to know you well, but I know you've always been very important to Hordak! He misses you so much. Come with us! “she screamed

happily, until a stalactite bigger than her fell and stuck into the ground next to her . Wow oHordak! He

“Couldn’t we stop screaming before we were buried by a few hundred tons of rock ?” Nettossa said in a hushed voice, and Catra added.

“For now, Lonnie isn't here, or at least I can't see her. Let's quickly do what we have to do here and get back.” Catra said, looking around warily. She turned to the painting of the octopus-headed creature.

“Who is that catuku ?” she asked

“We're not exactly sure.” George said. “We didn't read that book thoroughly because it seemed awful.”

“My grandfather was very fond of her, but he was strange. I was a bit afraid of him myself.” Lance added. “I remember that Great Cthulhu was supposed to be a powerful and ancient being, one of the Great Old Ones.

“Oh, he's like She-Ra! Is She-Ra the great Old One?”

The men looked at her shocked.

“No, definitely not.” said George in a terribly serious tone.

“I heard about him.” Catra has broken. “His name was mentioned by Aize , a person from Eridani. It was supposed to be described in that book you were talking about.” she said, her voice strangely gloomy.

“Our book must be a copy of that work.” George wondered, but Catra shook her head.

“From what I understand, both the Book of Dead Names and the Thousand Thousand Masks were created simultaneously in many places in the galaxy.” Said Catra

"But what does this creature have to do with dead names?" Netossa asked. Meanwhile, Entrapta was scanning the murals.

“It's not about such dead names. They are names that have been forgotten for countless eons, which is, in a sense, made them dead.” George explained.

“I see.” Netossa said looking at the painting of the tentacle-headed giant and shuddered.

These discussions bored her, so she decided to move away. She went deeper into the cave, illuminating her path with chemical light. It was damp and smelled of fungus and mold. She considered turning back to the others, but decided she wasn't a little girl afraid to get a little dirty. So she walked on and suddenly she saw something moving among the stalagmites. She ran there, and saw a small fluffy creature. Curious, she walked closer and saw a small bird covered in down. He was blind and walked on four spider legs. From its wide beak, in which there were long hooked finches, a spiked tongue shot out. She winced in disgust, but then a toad the size of a small dog jumped out of the rocks and swallowed the bird-creature whole with a mouth full of sharp fangs . She squealed and jumped away from him, freezing everything in that part of the cave at the same time, but she slipped and hit her butt against the hard stone floor.

“Are you okay Frost?” Netossa exclaimed fearfully.

“Yep!” she said, rubbing her tailbone. She realized with disgust that she got dirty with something awfully, but then she lit the wall and, widening her eyes in amazement, called everyone.

“Come quickly! I found something really cool.”

They were standing in front of a huge painting. This time, in addition to white, a shimmering blue was added to it. It depicted She-Ra driving away the cone-shaped creatures and the many-eyed monsters with her light, some of whom were freed, but most were killed by their masters, who then hid underground.

“Catra, you of us know it best. Does She-Ra have blue hair and four crystal eyes?” Because it's starting to worry me… - said Netossa.

"I'm more concerned that someone is apparently cleaning this." Catra said.

She barely suppressed a disappointed sigh as she saw that Imp had returned safe and sound. *This Frosta really must be the most bumbling of the princesses if she can't even kill that filthy monster* she thought as Rogelio hugged Imp and Kyle looked reproachfully at the embarrassed Lonnie. Of course, that was actually a good thing, because the death of the mascot might have sobered the Comrade General at this point, and that was against the plans of Creeping Chaos, but the idea of a white-skinned freak being pierced by ice spikes was too tempting. She hated him with all her heart, but it was a common feeling between… Siblings? Because that's what their relationship was supposed to be.

“You didn't have to send him there! You only did it to annoy Catra!” Kyle shouted indignantly. At first she despised him as a useless weakling, good for nothing but good looks He was a pathetic coward. He was… a defect. But he had unwittingly turned out to be her greatest rival in the People's Rebelion. He was the voice of reason that kept Lonnie from the most aggressive actions. Her conscience, which was able to sow doubts in the heart of the Comrade General. It was useful at times, but slowly became a problem. She had to limit his influence somehow… which she had been doing for some time.

They were in side tunnels that stretched around and above the city. They were plain, unadorned, save for strange inscriptions in the form of sets of dimples that she recognized as Elder Things' speech. Unfortunately, she didn't know much about this ancient race, she didn't expect to come across any remnants of it during this journey.

The trip was unexpectedly prolonged and she was beginning to worry. For now, she held out in Scarlet's body, but she already felt some discomfort, and there was still a way back. He will survive, he must, but the sooner they return to Castle Crypto, the better.

They entered the tunnels by a side entrance, following the road that started at the foot of the mountain and went around it. It was wide and almost not eroded, it was only covered with sand and sometimes rubble. There they found the entrance to the anthill-like interior of the underground part of the settlement. It was damp darkness all around, though here and there they could see traces of green phosphorescent fungi, although it was often overgrown by the ubiquitous crab spiders , and grew most densely on their corpses, so they agreed it was better not to approach them. The part of the city located in the cave was only a small part of the entire metropolis. There were hundreds of ledges and galleries on the walls, and a veritable maze stretched in the walls and smaller caves. There were warehouses and other rooms, perhaps workshops or greenhouses. Some of the tunnels were too small for a creature larger than a cat to squeeze through. There was at least one in every major room. At first she thought it was some form of pneumatic mail, but when she saw the many hooked hooks for climbing, she began to guess what these tunnels really were. Her suspicions were confirmed by Kyle when he pointed to a small picture of a multi-eyed monster.

“What is this creature? One like this supposedly killed She- Ra!” Kyle screamed in fear .

“It's Shogoth . A servitor race of the Elder Things, created and controlled by them. she explained to the boy, as if explaining that fish swim in water. “Probably used these tunnels to move around the city without blocking traffic. They were huge and extremely dangerous.”

"Are there… could there be any more here?" There was horror in Kyle's voice. She made a thoughtful face and shrugged.

“Who can know?” she asked rhetorically and inwardly laughed with cruel joy as Kyle shuddered.

So now, as Dr. Moors reported to Lonnie on his espionage trip, she silently waited for an opportunity to use it for Crawling Chaos' plans.

"I have to admit that Hordak's former right-hand doesn't seem bothered by your presence." said Dr. Moors, using exactly the words he should have used to arouse Lonnie's ire. The brain in the cilinder went off on its own after the Imp returned to them with horror in his eyes. He could move with surprising agility when he felt like it. Now Rogelio looked at him reproachfully, for he had been carried him on his back for most of the trip. Lonnie pursed her lips angrily and asked.

“What does she do?” asked Comrade General.

"I think he mostly looks at the paintings, historically interesting enough, but pretty useless to you." said Dr. Moors in that polite metallic voice. She didn't trust the Horde scientist, though she didn't trust anyone after Scarlet's death, but for now he was very useful. She just wondered how much he or his buzzing overlords were aware of her true nature or Nyarlathotep's plans , though was there anyone in the entire cold universe who knew them?

Lonnie spun around, fists clenched and panting heavily. It wouldn't have been an insult to anyone else, and Catra certainly didn't mean to offend Lonnie, but Comrade General was in a wonderfully lousy mood, perfect for her plans.

“Who else was there?” she asked terribly calmly. L o

"I've never seen any princess except for Scorpia and Adora with… my own eyes, but from the descriptions I've heard, they were Netossa, Frosta." Kyle shivered here . “And Entrapta.”

When he mentioned that last name, Lonnie turned sharply to the doctor. She felt like she didn't fully understand something. When the doctor mentioned Entrapta, he seemed to want to say

something else. As if he reminded about something that Comrade General didn't like very much. Had Lonnie made some commitment to Mi-Go that she had no intention of fulfilling? What could the mushroom -beetles want from her that she didn't even tell her closest friends and lovers. Very interesting.

“Is that all, no guards?” she asked in a voice as hard as granite.

“Onlytwo men, middle-aged and not giving the impression of travelers or posing any threat.” said the doctor.

“So they're outnumbered us. No point in messing with them," Kyle said , relief evident in his voice, but Lonnie shot him a stern look.

"Enrapta never fights anyone, and these two don't look like warriors…. “ She answered the blonde sharply.

"They have a elemental princess…" Kyle interjected .

“One and it's Frosta ! Who cares about Frosta?” Lonnie growled

“I care a lot about her.” Kyle said . "Netossa was the main strategist of the rebellion, and Catra…” He bit his tongue.

“Catra has always been the best at using others. First us, now her girlfriend. No matter how she protests, she will always be Shadow Weaver's apprentice.” drawled Comrade General with icy fury in her voice. “We have weapons that this planet has never known, and most importantly, our cause is just.

Kyle wanted to add something, but she felt the discussion beginning to tire her.

“Our advantage is surprise. Not only do they have no idea we're armed, but they don't even know I have magic. If we play it right, we can win.” she said with absolute certainty in her voice, hoping to convince the others to take action.

Lonnie thought for a moment, then nodded.

"It's settled, let's just try not to hurt anyone, not even Catra, unless we're forced to." said Comrade General.

“Especially watch out for Entrapta. We cannot afford to lose the greatest…mind on Etheria.” Dr. Moors said , and then she guessed what the secret deal between Lonnie and Mi-go was all about, and even she felt uneasy about it.

“Who do you think she was? And also what she was…” Netossa said quietly, and then she reflected and explained. "In terms of what species she was."

George rubbed his chin thoughtfully as he looked at the painting of the previous She-Ra and said.

“I'm not sure, it has features typical of the Etherian fauna, but I've never heard of a similar people”

She stared at the image for a moment, so close and so alien at the same time. Slowly she realized who that being was, and an infinite sadness gripped her heart. She looked down, tears streaming down her face. –

"I know who she is...was and who her people were...Adora once told me that Razz said she was always She-Ra... Only Mara wasn't fully She-Ra because she needed a sword to transform, like Adora in the beginning. The First Ones didn't create She- Ra ... She was always here...” She turned to her friends. “They stole her power, but in order to do that they had to kill the real She-Ra, and with her all her people... They weren't the First colonizers of Etheria... They were her first conquerors. They... murdered the original inhabitants of Ethetia ... erased all memory of them...” She opened her eyes to look at everyone's faces. Now their horror was reflected as they fully grasped the significance of the discovery they had made. There was silence in the darkness, to her cat eyes full of shades of gray. Her companion approached her and put his head under his hand to comfort her. She knew she should feel

despair and shame, some sense of guilt over the tragedy that had befallen the true inhabitants of the planet. She breathed air and drank water that never really belonged to her. "But this planet was never mine, was it?" she thought bitterly.

“Entrapta , could you scan this place with your satellite, I don't want to stay there any longer.” she said in a hoarse voice. The former Lady of Drill blinked and looked at her datapad . After a moment she said.

"Weird, Suzan says she can't detect anything here, as if something is masking everything here... It actually makes sense if the place is easy to find, it's the First Ones..." The violet-haired woman paused.

“Then they would destroy this place to hide all traces of their Crime. Even Mara probably didn't suspect anything, at least until very end.” she said quietly.

Suddenly her ears heard a grinding on the ceiling, saw movement in the gray gloom, then a metallic voice.

“Indeed, wonderfully correct Analyze Catro . I always thought Shadow Weaver underestimated your intellect. Mine too, which didn't stop her from sending me to the border with Dryll , but it was good. I met new friends there who gave me this wonderful body.”

She saw a black cylinder of black metal descending on metal tendrils from the ceiling.

"You probably don't recognize me in this new form, but I am Doctor Moors ." he said, moving closer to them. She felt the hairs on the back of her neck stand up and Melog began to growl all blue.

“Oh! A bot with the personality of a true scholar! Why didn't you ever tell me there was someone like that! It's fascinating!” Entrapta called in an excited voice.

“Not quite.” the Doctor explained, and then a small flap slid open and through the thick glass they saw that there was a brain inside. Now came a moment that no one expected. Entrapta was speechless at the sight of this new technological marvel, and not from delight. There was pure disgust on her face. She wasn't surprised.

“Well, from the greatest scientist on our planet, I expected a much more open mind. As the saying goes, you shouldn't get to know your heroes. But this bitter disappointment was compensated by something else... The scanners and other apparatus my friends gave me gave me a lot of fascinating news about you Catra, though...”

“What do you want and what are you doing here?” she asked, wanting to change the subject because she guessed what the nightmare scholar was referring to.

“I would like to say that I am here talking to you driven by scientific zeal and the desire to better understand the reality around us, but with sincere sadness I must admit that I am only here to distract you.” and sprang towards Entrapta with tentacles outstretched.

She saw movement out of the corner of her eye, and turning to see Kyle holding some strange weapon in his hands that looked like an creature wrapped around his forearm. She rushed towards him, and when he saw it, he screamed in fear and began to back away. In fact, he'd never really been afraid of her, because although she often teased him, she never did anything to him. Now she was really annoyed, she hadn't felt this way in years, and she looked pissed offness personified. He shot at her without even trying to hit her. Several shots hit the floor, which was covered with frost. *Where did you get such a weapon?* she thought in surprise. She sprang towards her former Horde comrade-in-arms, hoping to somehow disarm him, but then Lonnie stood in her way, clutching a strange metal staff.

“Leave him bitch!” She screamed and hit with all her might. She dodged, the staff's swipe accompanied by a wail that made her ears ache. As the staff slammed into the stone floor of the cave, it shook so hard that dust and small stones rained down from above.

“You're about to blow it all up! she shouted to the Comrade General, but she just smirked and continued to attack her. With each blow, the entire cave trembled. During this time, Entrapta effortlessly freed herself from the grip of Doctor Moors, whom Lance, George, and Melog were now fighting, and turned unexpectedly to Kyle .

“Biotechnology is really amazing! Where did you get it from?”

Kyle he looked at his gun and scratched his h” ead.

“I guess you can say that we bought them ...said the blond boy in a pensive voice.

“Kyle, would you kindly not fraternize with the enemy!” Lonnie snarled, then hissed as she slipped on the ice formed by Frosta, hitting her knee painfully. The Ice Princess laughed loudly, but then screamed and froze paralyzed as she was hit with a spell. She saw a woman in shadow with crimson hair holding a sorcerer's staff in her hands. *Scarlet? When and where did you learn to do magic?* she asked herself when she saw a friend she barely remembered. At that moment, George cut off the Doctor's tentacle with his sword, which, judging from his expression, surprised himself, but the terrifying scientist snatched the weapon from his hand and hurled it at Kyle, narrowly missing him. Netossa threw an energy net at Lonnie, but Lonnie just smiled and jumped towards the energy barrier and disappeared for a moment, then appeared in front of the ruler of Armori and hit her shoulder until they heard a loud crunch and the white haired woman screamed. Then she jumped on Lonnie and tried to cut her, but the general's companion only hit the stones painfully with her knees and one of her legs twisted at an unnatural angle.

“Enough Lonnie, give up!” she snarled menacingly and pulled out her claws, but her former cadet smiled crookedly and said.

“You don't give me orders anymore!” She touched it with the tip of her staff. Then she felt her mind go limp, bliss taking over her, she just had to give in to the external pressure. She knew that feeling all too well. Horde Prime had done the same to her, much more forcefully and brutally, but it was still a violation of her being, an assault on the sanctity of her self. Melog yelled and backed away from fighting the doctor. With violent fury, she pushed it away and slashed Lonnie's startled face with her claws. Then loud gunshots rang out. She saw Rogelio striking blindly with some heavier weapon. Everything started shaking

“Grab Frosta , the whole cave will collapse soon. Netossa shouted. She turned towards the youngest member of the expedition, who had just regained control over her body and trapped Scarlet's legs in the ice, but the sorcerer cast another spell and the blue-haired girl began to look around as if she did not know where she was. She reached out to pull it out, but Frosta looked at her and she screamed furiously.

“Hands off Horde scum.” and hit her hard in the face with an ice fist. Then the cave collapsed...

Among the princesses

Among the princesses

She smiled as Wrong Hordak introduced her, although she knew that now she would never be Adora to them , but She- Ra'a , the heroine of the galaxy ... but when she looked at them, it turned out that they reacted completely differently than she expected. Itel summoned a spectral blade, and Rosie clenched her fists, which began to glow. Both took a fighting stance. Eti was nowhere to be seen. The lizard named Alatar sighed and spoke over the com

“Hey, they're fine. You don't have to hide.”

“Now the only question is whether it's Alatar or maybe an ugly impostor.” A voice came over the lizard's communicator. The red dot of the laser sight appeared on his chest, but the silver scales signaled that he had nothing to worry about.

“Is Eti always so… nervous.” Perfuma asked cautiously .

“A bit, she hit me once, but after getting to know her, she turns out to be very nice.” said Wrong Hordak in a gentle voice. He really has changed a lot. Not only did he look different, he was now so colorful Catra would say his eyes hurt from looking at him. He became calmer, much more quiet.

'You better not talk to me, treacherous Wormdrak! You hid the truth from us from the beginning. And I was already starting to like you.” said the strange girl via communicator, and Wrongdak looked down, genuinely ashamed.

“She is right! You've been working with them from the beginning! You were an agent of cursed by devils and demons Etheria, a spy who was to learn our weaknesses and secrets for your dark overlords to enable them to conquer the galaxy and put us under the yoke of your wicked tyranny!” Itel screamed furiously. There

was silence… Even the guards stared at her in surprise. She blinked a few times, trying to follow the girl's reasoning. She, Scorpia , and Perfuma stared at Wrong Hordak asking him to explain what is going on with the green-haired Saihe. Even her White-Haired companion looked at Itel skeptically .

"You know, I think you're exaggerating a bit…" Rosie said.

“Nobody asked your opinion! You don't understand anything, you're stupid and naive.” Saihe yelled at her companion.

“Don't pick on Sparkling Hand. She's kind of right. The Blondie is definitely not the Lady of Chaos, she's too stupid for that. She is such idiot that wants to talk with Stinka! Who in their right mind would want to hang out with someone like that?”

She smiled sadly to herself because the girl reminded her of Catra, though she couldn't say why. Probably because of that cat's tail sticking out from under her coat, which she nervously waved all the time. But then she frowned, understanding what the girl was talking about.

"You're talking about the crap the Horde Ultimate says… She didn't know that someone who lived in his Empire wouldn't take that crap seriously." she said smiling sadly. "But I assure you, I'm no Chaos Lady... Rather, everyone tells me I'm too decent. My fiancée says my clothes are made to cut potatoes.” She laughed amiably. Perfuma and Wrong Hordak were about to say something, but Eti cut in

“Listen me Blondie. We don't know what it was like under Crookface's rule, but we from outside the Zone, when we see that there may be something terrible somewhere, there will definitely be something even worse. That's how the real world works... And besides, Itel is paranoid and doesn't like anyone.” Her voice was strangely colorless and dull.

"So you're from outside the empire?" She looked at Wrong Hordak . He nodded his head and said.

“Yes... Entrapta asked me to help her prove that Horde Prime was a liar and did not conquer the entire universe. And that's true. My Skittermander friends took me to Vesk III and I had a few happy years there with Emily.” he said, and Emily chirped yes and added looking at his young friends. “My brother has forbidden me to mention Etheri to anyone, because you know.” He looked at her significantly.

"What is this Hordak up to?" she thought, frowning.

“That's what we wanted to tell you”. Perfuma said and pointed to the lizard and the red-haired girl with long ponytails and a flower in her hair. This Itel looked as if she'd seen something terrifying . "These kids are from a planet outside the Empire." Their home world… I'll explain later…” Perfuma said and suddenly jumped in fright as Eti suddenly appeared behind her.

“What have you done to Lilka? she exclaimed strangely calmly, but gesticulated indignantly.

“She didn't do anything to me. Mrs. Perfuma gave me a flower and Mrs. Scorpia hugged me.” The redhead said with delight, and Eti jumped back violently.

“You're not Lilka. You are the imposter!” There was a note of indignation in the masked voice.

“I'm no imp ! Mrs. Perfuma simply gave me a flower because I apologized nicely for atack her with an axe. Lila explained.

“And yet no, you are very Lilka. Eti said and looked at the others. “As soon as you give us a lift, we will find Odora without any problems ... I will always find her after the smell, even in the darkest valley, where she probably comes from.

Scorpia and Perfume looked at the girl in bewilderment, but Rosie explained.

“This is Lady Cala Grayskull . She is great and brave, only Eti has some prejudices... And her ancestor, Mara, was from you, from

Etheria!”

“It's amazing.” Perfuma whispered, and Scorpia nodded.

“Really, there's absolutely nothing good about it. But at least Bina will be happy.” Eti explained.

“Are you sure?” Rosie asked cautiously.

“Of course!” She sure missed us!” Eth assured.

Adora and the two princesses turned out to be quite nice. They didn't look like princesses at all. They didn't have a tiara and white dresses... Though what could she know? She's never met one. Maybe it was local style? For example, if the Vesk had a princess, she'd probably wear a military helmet and armor... and be armed to the teeth... Actually, she'd look like a regular Vesk only more so.

She waved to one of the guards, who looked at her in dismay. She had the impression that all the guards were eyeing them suspiciously. She was not surprised by them, because first Lilka threw herself with an ax at Scorpia , and Eti was herself. She didn't understand how they and Itel could suspect Adora and her friends of being gangsters. And they offered them a ride. Everyone here respected them greatly, especially Adora . She was that She- Ra'a , though she wasn't sure what that meant... But she was definitely a good person since she defeated that monster Horde Prime ... She must have been a great a general with a mighty army, or a mighty wizard with unparalleled power. She just didn't look like that. She seemed perfectly ordinary, and compared to Lady Cala, she was almost a gray mouse. She wasn't as beautiful or tall or smart…especially as smart as a Carurystal aristocrat.

They were just getting into an army truck covered with a tarpaulin. It was not the vehicle she had expected from princesses and heroes. Several other military vehicles surrounded them, only

one that looked… decent. It was probably an old Horde vehicle, because its shape resembled those droids with which it fought in the underground. The rest looked like someone took normal vehicles and just repainted them. She felt as if they had been patched and repaired over and over again to make them usable. Though to be honest, she didn't know much about vehicles. On Absalom, she used public transport, and what happened before that, she couldn't remember. Adora walked over to her and, seeing that she was watching their convoy, said.

“Does the look weird? Everyone here keeps apologizing to me for such wretched machines *Unworthy of the Princess of the Power and savior of the universe*, but I don't know what they mean. Where me, my fiancée, and Scorpia grew up, it was all shaking so much you were rattled for two hours, and I didn't know about seat belts until Darla… it's such a ship.”

“So where were you born?” Rosie asked in surprise.

"I don't know, but I grew up in the Fright Zone..." When she saw Rosie recoil at the name, she added. “Ya, this place was as terrible as it was called… But now I live in Brightmoon with my fiancée Catra.” Adora said.

“Yes, Wrongdak mentioned her. He said Eti looked like her”. She looked at the feline girl who was with Alatar and Wrongdak at the engine of one of the cars.

“Ah, we have many catpeople on Etheria, but Catra is different from them.” the blond woman explained to her, and Rosie nodded.

“Yes, in the Galaxy they are called Pahtra and live on Vesk V, but Eti is not like them either. She was explaining to Adora, but then Lilka came up to them with a large package of bacon crisps.

“Please try. These are delicious crisps, bacon ones. I wanted to give Perfuma, but she says she doesn't eat meat, so I said it wasn't there, only, as Alatar says, the whole table of chemical elements, but she didn't want to eat them anyway.” the “orc” girl

explained. Adora tasted one carefully, smiled contentedly, then devoured half the packet at a time. Lady Cala had better manners, too.

Immediately after, one of the guards called them over and they jumped together into the back of the truck. She motioned for Eti to look at her, then turned off the reader and began speaking to her in sign language.

“Eti, but why are you always wearing a mask?”

A long moment passed before Eti replied.

"I don't like people staring at me, any more and they'll start asking me if they can pet me. And besides, I don't want my enemies to know where I am.”

She looked at it skeptically.

“Your enemies aren’t here”

“Their claws reach so far, you can't even imagine how. Who knows, maybe they're already here...”

They drove for two hours. But she couldn't take a nap, even though she was terribly tired, even exhausted. She tried to sleep on her wife's shoulder, but it was shaking so much she couldn't, so she put her head on the pillow in Scorpai's lap and let her stroke her. Then Lilka came up to her and asked.

“Is something wrong with you, Miss Perfuma?”

She smiled sadly at her.

"Nothing, just my power bring nature back to life, but it's… exhausting me." she replied, trying to be gentle.

“You know, thanks to you everything is green and alive anew You make everything beautiful again, not dirty and gray. You are the best my flower.” Scorpia kissed her tenderly on the forehead. Lilka thought for a moment and spoke in a calm voice, her eyes becoming misty.

“Once upon a time there was a girl named Lilka who lived on a farm. They cultivated cucurbits, melans, and pearples trees grew in orchards. And there were lots of flowers everywhere, especially in Lilka's mum's garden, and when it was spring, everything was so colorful... and they were all happy, they loved each other very much, and then... then… do you want a snack? This one's not bacon flavor, it's onion ones.” She handed her a packet of crisps, but she barely noticed. The tragedy hidden in the girl's words broken her heart.

“Who looks after you?” Scorpia asked with concern in her voice.

“Well, we're adults now, so no one has to, but I guess that's Bina.” said the girl. They looked questioningly at Alatar, who was staring at the datapad with concentration, on whose screen some colorful blocks appeared, which then disappeared. The lizard looked away from her and said.

“Bina is the captain of our ship. And then there's the sorceress Ireanis and Mr. Ilemshaw, our science officer. Now there's Miss Daisy, but she's one of the passengers we're carrying. She is a tutor of Lady Cala and a powerful shadow sorceress.”

" What a coincidence, because me, Adora, and her fiancée were raised by a shadow sorcerer." What an amazing coincidence!.” her wife.

“And you're all from Kesler?” she changed topic.

“Rosie is also a passenger, and Eti ... it's a complicated story.” answered the lizard.

“Eti looks like someone who was not hugged in childhood, and not enough love was shown.” Said her wife.

The lizard looked at her surprised.

“This is the most accurate and at the same time the most euphemistic description of Eti's childhood that you can imagine.”

Calamity found the trip to the city much less boring than she had expected. From the information she possessed, it appeared that an efficient network of cultists was operating on Dedalus , and as she watched Clytaimestra , the capital of the country where they found themselves, she understood why. The inhabitants were more religious than most of the inhabitants of this planet and put up a fierce resistance to Horde Prime, for which he punished them in his typical brutal and crude manner. The feeling of disappointment towards traditional religions combined with high spirituality and a sense of loss has always been a good breeding ground for the formation of cults of the Great Old Ones and the Outer Gods. They were willing to offer power at a price, but power always had a price. It is and always will be.

The sight of an armored personnel carrier did not cause as much surprise here as in other, quieter places. A little more interest was aroused by the sight of visitors from other planets, but only for a short time. After all, this world had once been a center of interplanetary commerce, so the sight of aliens didn't shock anyone here. She was pleased to see that she attracted the most interested looks. After all, it was her duty to evoking admiration, her destiny. That's what she was made for! The joy, unfortunately, passed when she discovered the reason for such reactions of the inhabitants of Dedalus . "See? She looks like her! He looks just like She-Ra!” To hell with them! It was hard for her to keep from extending her claws and tearing their throats open. Instead, she gave them the kindest Lady Cala’s smile she could muster on her perfect face.

Bina did her shopping, haggling fiercely, which was greatly facilitated by the presence of Dilayla, who, clad in power armor, kept pickpockets and more dangerous thugs away. Arkan tar

looked at several stalls selling souvenirs or antiques, where he bought a few trinkets. Rechiza spoke to a couple of priests who, judging by their robes, were members of some local branch of the Temple of Desna or the Star Butterfly. The three of them exuded a sense of guilt that they hid poorly. The most half-elf. She was the closest to the crew and even slept with Bina a few times, though they were hardly a couple. In truth, she herself wasn't sure what to make of their ally's true nature. Surely it was another variable in the already complicated plan of Creeping Chaos. She didn't share Shadow Weaver's preposterous terror, of course, but it would have been far better if the Lord Admiral hadn't reached Etheria, at least until their mission was complete. After that, Antares can make sausages from Etheria's inhabitants, he will even give him the Grayskull family recipe. Especially since there was a Star Stone there. The power of the most powerful artifact in the galaxy completely changed the course of their mission and explained so much. But why had Nyarlathotep kept it from her?

Bina was finalizing the purchase of smoked fish and canned anchovies, though the locals wanted a lot for their wares, but the captain had money, so she didn't skimp. She should have been curious as to where this woman was getting such funds, but she figured it didn't matter. She was almost certainly not a player in the great game that was being played out of sight of mere mortals. Only that nasty and twisted feline girl, but she, like with Catry and Adora, had to come to terms with their existence, however painful it was.

And then she saw a crowd, the people of Clytemnestra gathering around a caravan full of vehicles of all kinds. Most of the vehicles were escorts. Numerous guards in richly inlaid relatively modern armour, stylized as ancient, protected a group of people. But she heard the whispers of those gathered around her and knew that the passengers definitely did not need protection. First, a muscular woman came out, supporting a tall blonde girl with flowers in her hair. Through the stories, Shadow Weaver recognized Scorpia and Perfume in them . Bina turned to them and regarded them with bored curiosity. But as more people began to come out, Bina's eyes widened first, and then she turned

red. Wrongdak and Entrapta's idiotic invention came out of it first . The clone waved happily at Bina, not really noticing how furious the woman was. Dragonkin and a stupid girl who thought she was an orc followed right behind them, followed by an elf and Rosie. The nasty feline creature was nowhere to be seen. They all looked embarrassed that they hadn't stayed in the ship, or maybe just because they had been caught? She didn't really care. At the end she came out. When she saw her, she was disappointed. She was so… ordinary. Fairly pretty by mortal standards, reasonably fit, but really nothing special. *How could such a pity thing steal my destiny from me. What cruel twist of fate caused such a mediocrity to become She- Ra?* she thought with hatred and contempt boiling in her heart.

“Oh, I think someone will die here soon ...” Bina drawled and moved with fury painted on her face, she went towards her charges. No one noticed the venomous smile on Calamita's face .

"Unfortunately not," she whispered under her breath with a hint of sadness in her voice. She walked slowly towards Adora. The sky was covered with blue clouds, a storm was slowly approaching. With her inhuman senses, she sensed its violence approaching over the entire city. She walked among the Icarians. The guards paid no attention to her, they were focused on Bina yelling at the kids. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Captain Moonshadow staring at Adora. She saw wrath in the pirate's eyes, pure rage. It was very interesting.

“Or maybe someone will die ... - she whispered and came closer and extended her hand towards Adora.

"Hi, I'm Lady Cala Grayskull of Caryrustal.".

The return of the queen

Captain Moonshadow knew she should be pleased. The loot looted from the monastery guaranteed not only the reimbursement of the cost of the expedition, but also a huge profit. Gold alone, not even counting its potential artistic value, was worth a real fortune. In addition, there was also a monastery. They didn't even have to fear the wrath of the gods, because this place was desecrated by the Horde Prime, and they buried the dead inhabitants. Nevertheless, she gave tithes to Besmara , goddess of pirates, just in case, which was supposed to guarantee safety from the vengeance of competing deities. And most importantly, they got it somehow by the way, before they got there, to her lost home... Which, if you believe the Star Siblings, was not as terrible a place as they feared ... For a moment she considered imprisoning them in her Gardens of Long Death, but she thought that would be just mean. The morale among her crew rose to an impressive level. The old whining and snorting has gone into oblivion. She was again their beloved and a great captain who would give them glory and wealth. Some even suggested staying here for a year or two and, taking advantage of the chaos and ignorance of the locals, suspend the war with the Empire for a while and start the Great Hunt. With the wealth gained here, they will finally be able to field a real war fleet and become not a thorn in the side of the empire, but a knife stuck in the ribs of the Aeon Throne. She had to seriously consider that possibility, but first she had to exact her revenge. Punish traitors and slay the invaders.

She made a deal with Bina that they would land in a more desolate part of Icarus, where there were few cities and the central authority was not strong enough. No one here will trouble her crew if they don't look for trouble themselves. Her subordinates were disciplined enough that she didn't have to

worry about that. She was accompanied by Gozamund, who was the chief engineer aboard the Merciless. He was Nuar, a massive bull-like a humanoid whose race was famous for its love of technology and labyrinths. She had met him back on Jadehell at the labor camp, where he was a technician who repaired the air filters for the guards and other staff, which gave him the best protective gear, kept his lungs in good shape and didn't have to wear an assisted breathing apparatus. Aside from Tonada, who was almost in love with her, he was the most loyal of the crew, who had fought the Star Empire long before he came to camp and had never cared for wealth. Together they wandered the streets of Clytemestra arousing moderate interest. Although passers-by were probably deterred by the sight of the stern eyes visible above the mask. She was looking for… She wasn't sure what. She could rest in her cabin or train, but she came here because she had a strange feeling that there was something valuable here. Something she was looking for, though she didn't know it herself.

The city was very old, which meant nothing to her or any of her crew, and very poor, which made her heart ache. Already from orbit they could see that the area near the city was gray and barren, as if after using a powerful weapon of mass destruction. The food at the stalls was expensive, even considering that it had an unknown currency here. She saw the emaciated faces of children, though no one starved to death in the streets here. The local inhabitants gave the impression of being kind and willing to help their neighbours . That's why she stopped at the bakery and bought as much goods as she was able to carry, and she and Gozamund began to distribute them to the children. It was nothing to her, and these kids would finally be fed for one night. They tried to quickly separate the flat dark breads because a storm was approaching.

“Do you know that this is a drop in the ocean of needs?” said the bullman in Azlant, so that the kids would not understand what they were saying.

"But it's a drop that hollows out a rock," she replied to Nuar, although she had the impression that it was just an empty and

meaningless phrase. The children were not afraid of her. It always amazed her. Although she aroused terror in the hearts of enemies, she easily won the sympathy of the people, especially children. "But you're not just about handing out food."

“I've been fighting this fight for twenty years. Not because the Anti killed someone important to me or ravaged my village. I do it because I have to. But what did we do? We haven't even scratched the armor that protects the core of the Empire.” said Gozamund in a tired voice. She smiled under the mask.

“Look around. Horde Prime has oppressed the entire Zone for centuries. He held her in an iron grip so strong that the power of the Aeon Throne was like the touch of a velvet glove. It was a monster that destroyed entire civilizations on a whim. And he was annihilated in one day. By the inhabitants of this whole Etheria, by that She- Ra'a. *Etheria... My planet. Did I know you She- Ra? Did I expect rescue from you?* she thought as she handed out bread to the children, when suddenly a boy ran up to them and started whispering to the orange-haired girl. After a moment's hesitation, she left. A message passed between the children, and more and more of them ran off happily excited. The last boy practically snatched the loaf from her hand and ran away from her.

“Where are you going?” she asked in an amused tone. The kid stopped and cried out in a voice full of pure delight.

“There's Adora, you know, She-Ra from Etheri.” and they would disappear into the crowd, and she stood paralyzed.

Adora... The one who betrayed her, abandoned her to the void. She took her sword and everything she loved. She was She- Ra ... She should have known that. But it didn't change anything, absolutely nothing.

“Did something happen?” asked Gozamund in a frightened voice. She clenched her fists and grunted.

“Summon Tonada , Gydwa and Kaert . Let them appear. Immediately. And have Meriless summoned.” she said in a voice that sounded like death itself.

She tried hard not to stare at Eti's hand, at the brightly glowing symbols. "This is" she saw only on the hand sticking out from under the sleeve. She tried hard not to stare that way, but she was never very good at hiding what she was doing.

“You're looking for the last opportunity before the wedding?”. The green-haired Saihe growled at her.

“Last opportunity?” she asked, not understanding what was going on.

“To experience an nice time in the arms of a beautiful girl accidentally met far from home”. she explained venomously. She felt herself turn beet red. Saihe must have taken this as confirmation of her words, because she snorted contemptuously, but Eti said without interrupting the conversation with Rosie in sign language.

“Itel is terribly jealous of me, I don't know why, but I see you looking at my hand.” She paused for a moment, and now it was itel who blushed. “That's good, because it's a awesome hand!” Eti turned to her so suddenly that Rosie got scared and put her hand under her nose. “Look how cool it is.”

“Ugh Yes, it's interesting ... Especially the writing ...” she groaned. "Have you heard of a race of First Ones? I know this is going to sound weird, but I can see the writing on your hand and I can read the them. Do you know about them?” she asked carefully. The three girls looked at her surprised.

“It's a startongue. The Language of the Starlings . Eti explained. "I thought only I could see them." And I'm sure that no one can read them - said the masked girl, and the green-haired girl looked at her as if she wanted to say something, but changed her mind.

“Starlings?” she asked confused.

“Lilka, show your drawings!” called Eti a red-haired girl who was at their side in three steps and began to take out sheets of paper until she pulled out a large sheet with a drawing of a smiling star, the rays of which ended with the same metal hands as Eti's.

“You know, Starlings... The First Ones... look a bit different.” she said carefully. Scorpia, around whose neck Tosh snoring deliciously wrapped, and Wrong Hordak approached them.

“How!” Lilka shouted indignantly, and Eti added.

“These drawings are supported by the scientific consensus achieved by many years of research.”

Rosie rolled her eyes.

“Nobody knows what the First Ones looked like. They were said to be machines. We know that they built cities on Abbalon and created the race of Anacites. The Anacites worship them as gods!” Rose said.

She felt sweat running down her back. *Please not that.*

Scorpia smiled happily and rested her hand on Adora's shoulder.

“Our Adora is the Last of the First Ones.” said the Scorpion princess, and Adora stifled a groan with difficulty. Rosie stared at her with her mouth open, and Lilka looked from her drawing to her a few times and shook her head.

“You're not like them at all.”

Eti turned her head to the side and asked.

“So you're a living oxymoron, with emphasis on a moron ?

Scorpius leaned over her so that their noses were almost touching.

"You remind me so much of Adora's fiancée." she said, but Eti snapped back.

“You invade my personal space, I'll bite you!”

“Jeez, you really are so similar!

Then the vehicle stopped and Eti jumped away from Scorpia and activated the cloaking field. She really does look like Catra , she thought as she walked outside.

She sighed heavily as she saw the crowd gathering around her. *It's starting again. It's good that Eti and her friends don't care much about who I am.* she thought sadly. She saw the Wrong Hordak suddenly wave to someone, and the others faded. A woman with burgundy hair was walking towards them, her face red with rage. One guard tried to stop her, but she pushed him away.

“What the fuck did I tell you? How long did it take you guys to piss warm urine on my orders?!” she screamed at the top of her throat. Hearing the curses, she and Scorpia blushed.

"It's probably my fault..." Wrong Hordak began, but the woman didn't let him finish.

“A little bit, but mostly Itel. Not only did you put everyone in danger for who the fuck knows what, but you got Mr. Wrongdak and Rosie involved. Have you no shame?!”

“They had nothing to fear from us. “she tried to explain, but then the burgundy haired girl turned to her.

“And you don't fucking meddle in things that don't belong to you!” She roared at her until she backed away from her.

“Do you know who you’re talking to?” one of the guards said to her, but the woman turned to him.

“Do you know what do I care who this blonde is.” she growled, and the guard cringed as she looked at him with eyes full of fury .

"But nothing big happened, no need to shout like that..." Scorpia said in a friendly and conciliatory tone, but then the burgundy-haired woman jumped up to her.

“Do you have children? NO? So don't meddle in other people's upbringing!” she drawled and seemed to overwhelm the mighty Scorpion princess with her personality. It is said that the quarrels between Queen Angela and Glimmer were legendary, and sometimes the whole palace shook from them. She hadn't had a chance to experience them, but they probably looked similar.

Then a woman emerged from the confused crowd.

“Hi, I'm Lady Cala Grayskull of Carurystal” She said in a beautiful sonorous voice extending her hand towards her.

The guards looked at her in surprise. The burgundy haired girl said softly "We'll talk later" and started to watch them. Lady Cala was…extraordinary. She was taller than Perfume and nearly as tall as Scorpia. She moved gracefully, as if every step she took was an invitation to dance. She was beautiful, absolutely perfect... And that hair, how did she make it so fluffy and shiny?

She noticed him staring at her, so she shook the outstretched hand. The woman also squeezed her hand. She was surprisingly strong despite her delicate build.

“Ughh. I'm Adora, you know, She-Ra, Princess of Power and all.” she said, feeling oddly shy around the woman. She had the impression that she was spreading an aura of majesty around her, overwhelming like the glare of the sun, from which the stars faded.

“Oh! We heard about you from Star Siblings. They say you're the greatest hero in the galaxy, the one who defeated Horde Prime alone!” she said with delight in her voice, which made her blush.

“Well, definitely not alone. I wouldn't have done much without the help of my friends. Meet Princesses Scorpia and Perfume “ She pointed to her companions. Scorpia looked smitten, but Lady Plumeria eyed Lady Cala uncertainly.

“Oh, we've heard a lot about you too!” said the thunder princess. Lady Cala laughed sonorously.

"I'm sure Rosie and her friends have told you about me, though Eti probably isn't very nice. Sometimes I have the impression that she is a little jealous, unnecessarily, because she is a great girl!” said the beautiful woman. She noticed Eti, who suddenly appeared behind Lady Cala and made a very insulting gesture, and then disappeared again.

“Yes, great ...” she muttered under her breath and asked. "So you came here to the empire... To Horde Prime's Former Empire because..." she asked, not knowing how to direct the conversation to the topic she was interested in.

“Because I'm looking for Etheria, the planet where the founder of my family - Mara - came from.” Lady Cala smiled softly.

So it's true, she's talking to Mara's descendant now! They weren't exactly alike, but after all, a thousand years or more had passed... So many generations...

“But it turned out that Etheria found me herself... Did you know that you have a Starstone at your place?”

She blinked several times not understanding what the woman was talking about.

“Starstone?” she asked Lady Cala , and the beautiful woman was about to answer them when there was a hard scream

“ADORA!”

Everyone turned to where the voice came from. She saw a tall woman wearing purple robes. She had a mechanical prosthetic

arm instead of a right arm, and she wore a mask of some blue crystal over the lower half of her face. For a moment she wondered how she knew her, and then she spread translucent wings reinforced with a metal frame and took off her mask. Then tears came to her eyes.

“Do you remember me!” said Queen Angela in a voice sharper than the Sword of Protection.

“Of course I remember you!” she called. Now tears were streaming down her cheeks. "You're alive… you're really alive," she thought, feeling joy singing in her heart. She never fully accepted that the queen had sacrificed herself for her, had given her life for her. Catra was always haunted by the fact that she had taken her friend's mother away. But now everything will change! No more mourning and remorse! The queen is back! Mikah ... oh Mikah, how happy he will be!

Then several people appeared next to Queen Angela. The first was a small creature with blue fur on its body, wearing a pirate hat fur on its head. He would have been cute if it weren't for the six pirate sabers he was holding in his hands. He stood in front of Angela and glared at her menacingly. To the queen's right stood a great lizard similar to Rogelio , but much more massive. He had one eye and held a huge hammer in his hands, the surface of which was electrified. On the left appeared a large bullman , in whose hands suddenly appeared claws. Behind them stood Saihe in dark glasses, who was holding a blaster in his hand .

“It's would be strange that you don't remember someone you left to die.” Angela growled and coughed, then pulled the mask back over her face.

“But Angela… Queen. - she said. She could said that the queen herself had decided to stay on the other side, but what did it matter? It was because of her, because she failed, because she wasn't strong enough, that all of this happened. She didn't want to defend herself . Yes, she abandoned her… To a fate worse than death. She felt her legs buckle under her. Thunder struck and the

first drops of rain began to fall from the sky among which her tears were lost Angela looked at her surprised.

“Angela…so that's what my name used to be.” she said thoughtfully and shook her head. "Never mind… I am Captain Moonshadow, sword for Azlanti, captain of the terrible Meriless. My enemies speak my name in horror. You will too. Let's make this arrangement. You come aboard my ship and tell me where you keep the sword, and no one will be harmed. Hardly anyone.” she said with a threat worthy of the most feared predator. Among the blue storm clouds appeared a great black ship that had apparently just shed its cloaking field. The crowd began to retreat, and the guards closed their ranks uncertainly looking at the woman completely unknown to them.

“I will go with you. she said sobbing.” Perfuma and Scorpia tried to talk to her, but she didn't listen. "I can't give you the sword... It was destroyed... I broke it... I had to."

Desperation flashed in the Captain's eyes, then she shook her head and screamed in uncontrollable fury.

"You're lying, but after some days in the Gardens of the Long Death, you'll tell the whole truth, I assure you!" And she raised her hand. The tattoos that covered her glowed, and a gray-blue flare appeared in her left hand. She took aim at it, unwilling to defend herself, feeling her body go numb. Then Lady Cala stood beside her, sword drawn, and screamed.

“Enough of this Moonshadow. Give up!”

Angela looked at her irritably.

"So you're breaking our agreement, noble lady?" She growled and hurled a energetic projectile from her hand at her. Lady Cala ducked and the shot hit one of the guards, who screamed in pain. The warriors accompanying Moonshadow rushed into the fight, Screams, gunshots and the clash of weapons snapped her out of

her stupor. She stood and looked up. She saw the ship take a firing position.

“Surrender, Adora , or this city will burn.” Glimmer's mother threatened. She closed her eyes and took a deep breath. S

“For the honor of Grayskull!“ she screamed, and felt magic flowing through her, pure power. She thought of Catra, her beloved and her friends, Glimmer, Bow or Skorpia and Perfume standing nearby. This allowed her to transform, to become She- Ra . When the flash of rainbow light passed, she opened her eyes and looked at the shocked Angela .

“You come with me. To daughter and husband…” She said in a gentle but firm voice.

“You're lying! They are dead! Fire!” the queen shouted and wanted to shoot at her, but she effortlessly blocked the projectile with her sword, and then Lady Cala attacked.

?I'll take care of her. You stop the ship.” said the woman. Her hair blew in the wind despite the rain, as did She- Ra 's . She nodded to her and jumped towards the black ship, hovering against a dark sky criss-crossed with lightning. Just then, the ship's hull-mounted gun began to load, and she directed her flight to intercept the shot. Then the ship fired, spitting out a huge ball of plasma capable of burning an entire district of the city. She transformed her sword into a shield and took a hit on it. Flames as hot as the sun itself surrounded her, but the shield absorbed all the energy easily, though most beings would evaporate. She smiled, hoping the shooter could see her. Then she aimed her sword at the ship and sent a beam of light at it.

Eti blinked a few times. She was glad she was wearing tinted goggles or the flash of rainbow light would blind her. Then she saw Blonde who became BLONDE. She was almost two and a half meters tall, and her hair blew in the wind as if it were made of

light itself. When Stinka stood next to her, she looked pathetic, as if she was trying to imitate an unattainable pattern… But Stinka was always pathetic. And she had a sword, big and sharp, not some stupid needle.

And then the blonde jumped towards the cruiser...

What do they put in these crisps Eti asked herself

“Is she going to fight with a pirate ship?| Alatar asked in surprise.

“Yeah , and we don't have much like so ... Where the fuck is Eti?.” Bina asked, but she wasn't listening. She wanted ran after Stinka ... This mean bitch will do harm to the captain of the Wingy . She liked the Wingy. Maybe not as much as Grimmy, but she was so cool! The mean woman was attacking the pirate with surprising for someone in the rain, avoiding the pirate's shots. At that time, Skittermander rushed at Vegi , and Veska and Nuar Nanocyte were attacking Stinger. Vegi wrapped Skitermander in vines, but then she had to dodge because the drow elf shot her with a pistol. Stinger grabbed the handle of the hammer.

"You know, I'm friends with a lizard like you, but he's not big as you..." said the scorpion woman.

"Because the Veska women are bigger." The other snarled, and then lightning bolts struck from Stinger's pincers, knocking Hammerhead back and hitting the cobblestones. Despite the fact that smoke was rising from her, she tried to get up. The scorpion woman was attacked by the bullman with his nanomachine claws, but Alatar cast a spell that made the bullman forget how to use the weapon. Skittermander slashed the vines and lunged at Vegi, shouting "For Captain Moonshadow", but then Lilka charged at him. Itel gracefully started attacking Veska , who was already on her feet. Bina shot at the drow - elf, only Sparkle Hand stared at the BLONDE as if she was going to jump into the sky after her. Her eyes were strangely cloudy

Then the ship fired and hit BLONDE... who instead of evaporating turned her sword into a shield and blocked the attack. Sparkle Hand curled up, covering his eyes. And then BLONDE changed her shield back to a sword and fired a beam of light at the ship, almost destroying his shields.

"Retreat! We're retreating to the ship!" Captain Moonshadow called, barely defending herself against Stinka's attacks. At that time, Piącha came running and struck right next to Hammer. The Pirates didn't need to repeat the order, they started to withdraw. They didn't pursue them, except for Stinka, who chased after Captain Moonshadow. She decided to check what this bitch was up to and find out what was actually going on here.

At the very beginning of her life, she could run on all four limbs. But then her left arm was maimed and her right arm was lost. She couldn't touch anything with the fingertips of her left hand, and the right hand was too slippery. If it weren't for the falcon boots, she wouldn't be running across the rooftops after a pirate and an aristocrat. She ran through the rain, avoiding being seen. There was a dogged chase under a sky streaked with lightning. With a smile on her face, Stinka dodged the shots with unprecedented grace, carrying out her attacks. The captain's robes were in tatters, and redblood leaked from between the armor plates. Suddenly, the two women reached the building, a four-story building with a flat roof. There was no escape from here. The aristocrat was facing the captain, who was breathing heavily, smiling like a cat at a mouse. She was preparing to deliver the final stab to the heart. Eti, without thinking, put the telescope to her eye and fired, hitting Stinka in the knee. Then Captain Moonshadow shot her straight in the face, then wrapped her wings around herself and disappeared. What happened next, she did not see. She preferred to run away before Stinka noticed her. Even though she was absolutely perfect, awesome and unique, she wouldn't stand a chance against her.

She landed on bent legs. She couldn't chase the ship, not at this level of power, and she didn't want to draw more. It could damage the ship, and for Glimmer's mother's sake, she preferred to avoid it. She looked around, she was alone in the street drowning in the pouring rain. Suddenly she saw something between the buildings, like a shadow watching her. Her heart froze for a moment as she thought of one person who had been dead for five years. But then the shadow disappeared as if it had never been there... Then Lady Cala emerged from the rain. In her arms she carried a child whose body was horribly shattered.

“It was Captain Moonshadow who did it.” the woman said in a pained voice. “Or asyou call her, Queen Angela.”

Nevermore

She grunted as she tried to push another boulder.

“It's no use. None of us will lift this boulder.” She said to her companions, panting heavily. She wiped her forehead.

“Nonsense!” cried Entrapta. " We just need to prop it up somehow or maybe make some explosives to blow it all up!" said the purple-haired girl and opened Alice, and then started throwing more items out of the bot. It's strange how so much stuff fits into such a small machine.

“How do you hide everything there?” she asked her friend.

“There's a space-time micromodulator. Thanks to this, the inside of Alice is ten times larger than the outside.” Entrapta explained without taking her eyes off the gathered tools. "It's like an inverted black hole. Almost harmless.”

“Almost?” Netossa asked, jumping up violently and wincing as she felt the terrible pain in her broken arm. The woman's arm was broken so that the bone was sticking out. Her and Lance, being the most medically trained of them all, set her up with some difficulty and put her in makeshift slates. The new drugs speeded up healing, but even so, there was little Lady of Armoria could do to help them get out of their prison. She thought bitterly.*It won't heal until the wedding.*

Things were a little better with Lance and George. They had some bruises and scrapes, and George had a slight limp, but they seemed to be more concerned about something else.

“It's a bit of a shame about this sword. He's been in your family for six generations, hasn't he? George asked his husband.

"You said he was ill-balanced anyway. To be honest, I don't really remember how it came into my family's possession.” Lance wondered. Entrapta emerged from the entire encounter unscathed, at least physically. What happened to Frosta was a complete mystery

Half the city was buried under the rubble that fell during the fight with Lonnie. They were trapped in its central part, near the painting of the former She- Ra. They were cut off from the exit and did not know how or if they would get out. To make matters worse, Frosta was trapped in another part of the underground complex and they didn't even know if she was alive. "It's all because of you, Lonnie. Next time we meet, I'll scratch more than just your face." She vowed to herself, looking at her claws covered with the blood of her former companion, although she wasn't even sure if Comrade General was alive. Knowing her luck, she certainly survived. Their relationship was always not the best ... Lonnie was constantly picking on her, treating her with contempt. She was called a cunning cheater and a mean egotist. In the first case, she was absolutely right, she had never been ashamed of her cunning. And when she became Hordak's right hand, she was very mean, she couldn't deny that either. But it was one thing for them to have a private rivalry, which she could accept, and quite another for her friends and all of Etheria to be involved in the conflict. "What about Kyle and Rogelio ?" She knew from Scorpia's stories that the three of them had become very close by the end of the war. A bit weird, but nothing really surprising. After all, they grew up together and shared all the hardships and miseries of life in the Fright Zone. Besides, she had neither the right nor the intention to judge them, not for that at least. But if anything happened to Frosta because of Lonnie ... She wouldn't survive the next time they met.

And then there was Scarlett. She hardly remembered her friend with red hair. The girl was genuinely lazy and was constantly getting minor punishments that she didn't care about. However, she was smart enough to stay away from Shadow Weaver. Considering she was a sorcerer, it was a really good decision… There were grim rumors in the Fright Zone about what happened

to Horde citizens who were discovered to have a talent for magic. They were going to be sent on Beast Island… at best. But it wasn't the cadet's newfound abilities that bothered her. She may not have liked sorcery, but she could deal with it. But what Doctor Moors had become and the new, completely unknown weapon at their disposal... and those allies that the scientist from nightmares had mentioned. This was a really serious problem that he had to let all the members of the alliance know about ... but in order to do that, they had to save Frosta first and get out of here.

Melog came to her from a reconnaissance trip. She patted her companion on the head and read the pictures he had sent her. She sighed and turned to the others.

“The situation is as follows. Melog found a passage outside.” Everyone was happy, but she added in a serious tone. “It is very narrow. Only Entrapta and I will be able to squeeze through, but I will with difficulty, and only because I have movable clavicles, the advantage of being a cat girl.” She smiled slightly and looked at the purple-haired woman, but she didn't even look at her.

“Entrapta , what do you think?” she asked her. Entrapta looked at her, and spoke in a calm voice, much calmer so than usual.

"I'm staying here, I'm pretty sure that if I think about it a bit... I have a feeling that the solution is at hand... Maybe we can reverse gravity..." She started looking for something in Alice again. she sighed.

"It's good that you're trying to help. It's always better than sitting on your ass doing nothing. But first of all, we must think about how we will free ourselves. Then we'll somehow reach the Silverwing and call for help, or we'll just fly for it." She calmly explained to her friend. The Former lady of Dryll covered her face with a mask and spoke in a hard voice.

“We're not leaving Frosta. We won't leave anyone else behind. Not this time.”

She pursed her lips and looked down at her toes. Entrapta was left behind in the Fright Zone during the mission to rescue Glimmer. Though the rebels had only left her because they believed the inventor was dead, Entrapta felt betrayed… which she later used diligently to recruit her for the cause of the Horde. The purple-haired woman had suffered a lot in the aftermath of these events, and she didn't want the same to happen to Frosta. The girl was perhaps brave, but also sensitive. It is unknown how he will endure being trapped alone in the dark, if he is still alive. "No, we can't think about that"

“Okay, Melog and I will go to Silverwing and notify someone in Brightmoon or Ice Palace. I'm the fittest of us all, and we can get there in one day if we work hard. You'll have enough supplies here for a few days. she said with a friendly smile and started packing.

“You know, maybe don't push yourself in your condition. We can wait a bit. Or just Entrapta will make up her mind and go alone after all. I'm sure I can do it too, this hand doesn't hurt that much. I may not be that young anymore, but I'm in great shape and I can pull my belly in. I know that Frosta is the most important right now, but can we rethink it?” Netossa said carefully.

“What do you mean by "My Condition". I'm fine…" replied the Grand Marshal, looking at the Lord of Armoria. Netossa sighed heavily.

"Well, in the Fright Zone probably didn't explain such things to you, but a pregnant woman shouldn't overextend herself." she explained to her.

For several heartbeats, she watched Netossa silently, mouth open, until she spoke.

“Pregnant... Why do you think I'm pregnant...”

Netossa looked at her, smiling radiantly.

“Well, you don't have to hide it from us anymore. You know, you have weird cravings, you have morning sickness, you're plotting something with Entrapta , because Adora is a First One and you're a Cat girl, and that can be a challenge.”

Lance and Georg's eyes lit up when they heard this news. They walked over to her and almost hugged her.

“It's amazing! You will be moms!” Lance called.

“And Bow and Glimmer will be uncle and aunt... Again.” said George thoughtfully.

Even Entrapta broke away from her calculations and ran to her.

“Child! It's great! How did you make them.” she exclaimed, and Netossa looked at her in surprise.

Only Melog looked as confused as she was. She took a deep breath and screamed.

“I'm not pregnant!” she said and everyone fell silent.

“So you're ill? Was that your secret? Netossa looked at Entrapta in horror. The inventor looked pleadingly at her, so she knelt down and said.

"I'm not sick and I'm DEFINITELY not pregnant. We only talked about it once or twice. No… it's just that… She closed her eyes and swallowed hard. “That I'm not from here ...” she said and clarified “I'm not from Etheri ...”

She finally said it aloud, though not in the company she had originally intended. But she felt relieved anyway.

Except for Entrapta , who had known all this for some time, the others looked at her with a mixture of shock and disbelief.

“But how ... after all, for a thousand years we were locked in Despondos ... No one could get here.” Netossa finally called, but

George said in a pensive voice.

“It's not so sure, if we take into account some stories and legends ... We all know two people who ended up here despite being cut off from the rest of the universe ... One of them was summoned here by Light Hope, and in the case of the other, her involvement is highly probable.” he said, eyeing Entrapta meaningfully , but she just shrugged.

“Hordak... he doesn't remember much from before he came to Etheria, and what he remembers he can't trust. For example, he remembers a battle with warriors in black armor who summoned terrible monsters to help. Some were Imp-like, others monstrous and terrifying. I never encountered Light Hope while she was active, and after the sword was shattered and she deactivated, her core self-destructed so I couldn't examine her.” The purple-haired woman explained thoughtfully

She snorted contemptuously. When ancient artificial intelligence was mentioned

"You have nothing to regret, but it's definitely not that mean bitch that brought me here. I came here in a carton of applesauce from a place called Kesler. I have no idea who sane would send a baby to another planet by putting it in a cardboard box? It wasn't the cardboard box that got me suspicious. I did genetic testing, you know, the usual pre-marital testing. And… did it turn out that I'm not from Etheria. I asked Entrapta to confirm it, and it turned out that the tests were done correctly, so… I asked Scorpia for the medical records of the cadets. I found very little about myself. Only Dr. Moors, the same one we met today in his own canned persona, suspected something, but he was also interested in Adora , so Shadow Weaver sent him to the Drill border, which was an act of great mercy for her. As we've seen, he seems to have done worse to himself than Hordak's deputy could think of. Our "teacher" obviously didn't bother to look at my test results, but maybe that's a good thing. Sometimes I think that I wish she was alive just so I could see her face when she finds out what secret

was right under her nose and she didn't see anything because of her arrogance and prejudice.” she laughed bitterly.

“Does… Adora know about this?” Netossa asked, who apparently had not yet recovered from the recent news. She shook her head and explained.

“I haven't had time to tell her anything. At first I wasn't sure about anything myself, and then she flew to Icarus , and I was gathering information. I promised myself that she would be the first to know everything as soon as she got back, but it turned out a bit differently… She smiled bitterly. There was silence for the next few minutes. She wasn't sure what else to add. So cuddle Melog behind the ears, and he was purring softly. Despite the difficult situation in which she found herself, she felt that her heart became lighter. Lance finally said.

“It must be hard for you.”

She thought for a moment and shook her head.

“Actually, no… You know, I didn't have a past outside of the Horde anyway. Was I abandoned by my parents in the Fright Zone, or was someone sent me here for a purpose known only to them, what does it change for me and Adora? We've always been together, and nothing's gonna change that.” she said firmly. It wasn't entirely true, because her origins might prove important in the future if they ever found whoever sent her here, but it was rather unlikely... "But this dream... No, it's just my fears, my fears that created it, nothing more".

She got up and walked over to the painting of the previous She-Ra and added.

"Actually, we're all strangers here." We all live on a planet that has been taken away from its rightful inhabitants. She clapped her hands suddenly and turned to the others with new energy in her voice.

“Enough of this idle talk! We have to save Frosta . We will not abandon anyone. Entrapta, do you still have that plasma heater packed?” She looked at the inventor, on whose face a wide smile appeared again.

“Oh, so we're going to make explosions after all?”

She smiled too and said.

“No, let's break some ice. At the top Melog could see the entrance to those side tunnels Lonnie had come in through, only it was blocked by a block of ice. If we melt it down, maybe we can get around this rubble. If not, we'll find another way. We will try until we succeed. Let's never leave anyone alone again. Nevermore”

She winced as Rogelio dragged stitch away, and regretted it as a spasm of pain ran all over her scarred face. The lizard growled apologetically, but she waved her hand to show him that he did nothing wrong.

"Even with a damaged tentacle, I'd better stitch you up." murmured Doctor Moors, sitting in the corner, welding a damaged limb.

“Not that I don't trust you, doctor ... but I don't fucking trust you.” She groaned, ignoring the pain.

You should, I'm a doctor. said the brain in the top hat, and burst into a surprisingly cheerful voice.

“You're a fucking talking can, not a doctor.” she groaned and let Rogelio treat her to the end . As she did so, she thought about recent events. “It was a failure. Damn failure." She thought as rage boiled in her veins. *I should have known Catra would resist the staff's charm. She was chipped by Horde Prime, and after that Shadow Weaver certainly used mind controlling magic on her. I should have foreseen that too Kyle won't hit anything,* she thought, looking at her blonde-haired friend. He avoided her gaze

and just leaned against the wall and watched as she got under her feet. In his hand was the idiotic ornate sword they had taken from the two elderly men. They couldn't use it very well, but Kyle couldn't use properly anything at all. She gritted her teeth furiously. That sword was their only gain from the quest... In exchange, they lost Scarlet, their only sorcerer... and damn Catra clawed her face. "I forgot how sharp they are." She thought a bit absently. *I hope it's not a fever, if it is, we're screwed.*

They hid in one of the side corridors, which turned out to be completely intact. She had to admit that the whole disaster was at least partly her fault. She shouldn't have slammed her staff against the walls of the cave with such force. She shouldn't have given Rogelio that sonic weapon, she shouldn't have pissed Catra off with mind control, and most importantly, she shouldn't have gotten involved in this fight at all. Everyone advised her against it, but she didn't listen to anyone. And now Scarlet was missing and possibly dead. It wasn't even that she was their only sorcerer, and a damned valuable spy in Mystacor. She was her comrade-in-arms, her right-hand man, and…damn, her lover. In fact, she didn't even like her much. She was strange, repulsive in her own way, sometimes reminiscent of Shadow Weaver, Entrapta, or even Hordak. But she was their companion, a cadet who had shared the hardships of growing up in the Fright Zone under the watchful eye of a dark sorcerer. He won't leave her here to die.

" Kyle , show me that sword of yours," she ordered as Rogelio finished his treatment and saw herself in the shining surface of the blade. She didn't even flinch when she saw what Catra had done to her face. The three long scars looked horrible and hurt just as bad. There will be scars for sure. She had heard once that Shadow Weaver scars were the price of power. She thought it was nonsense. The scars were the price of defeat, a reminder of failure. She knew that lost limbs could be replaced these days, let alone remove scars. Even Adora, with her She- Ra's power in all her arrogant benevolence, would probably cure her if she would just humble herself and apologize for fighting for justice. Only… she wouldn't remove them. They will be a reminder of her ineptitude and mindless resistance.

“What we do? Kyle asked.” “I know it would be wisest to find a way out and get out of here. But we can't leave her here. Scarlet... I know she and I didn't like each other, but she's one of us. We can't leave her here.”

She closed her eyes and spoke in the most confident voice she could muster now.

“Of course we won't leave her. While Glimmer was being rescued, Entrapta was abandoned in the Peril Zone, and that's where all the trouble started. We are different, better. Nobody will be left behind. Never more”

In the depths of the earth

“Does anyone hear me!” She called to the wall of stones standing immovably before her. No one answered, except for an echo and a loud sigh from that lousy sorcerer. So she formed fists of ice and began to hit the boulders with them, but they didn't even budge. She snarled and created a great ice hammer and swung it furiously, not stopping even as dust started raining down on her head. She finally broke off and stood panting heavily.

"Stop yelling or you'll throw rocks on our heads and they'll crush us this time… maybe that's what you want?" asked the sorcerer in an irritated voice.

"Why would I want something so awful!" She screamed as she ran up to the red-haired woman. Scarlett sighed.

"At best, we'll starve to death. Although I saw some underground animals and mushrooms here, so maybe we'll have something to eat and there are several lakes and moisture drips from the walls, so we'll survive somehow.” she said, and the sorcerer laughed grimly. She remembered the spiderbird and the toothed frog and shuddered.

"But our sources of light will eventually run out and we'll be left alone here, trapped in impenetrable darkness... I told you that I don't know the spell that creates light...? I found them useless.” Scarlet laughed again, but the laugh was devoid of hilarity. She felt a cold sweat bead on her forehead. She hadn't been afraid of the darkness in a long time, but to be trapped in the dark for… forever? It was too terrible to think about. She looked hard at Scarlet and said pouring all the confidence she still had in her heart into her words.

“We'll get out of here! We will find a way out, if not ourselves, then our friends, yours and mine, will come to our aid!”

The sorceress smiled sadly.

“You have great faith in your friends!” she said thoughtfully. She pursed her lips and called out.

“Of course! They will always help me. I do not doubt about it!”

The sorceress snorted softly.

"They don't even know if we're alive, not to mention they probably have to take care of themselves." she said resignedly. “People behave like that.”

She shook her head furiously.

“Not true! We're not like that, and I'm sure your friends won't leave you here either!” she cried out because she didn't want to… and she couldn't believe anything else. Catra was so brave and strong, Netossa was almost always the best Rebel general, Lance and George read almost every book in the world, and Entrapta is the smartest person in the universe! And then there's Melog, a true Magicat. Why wouldn't they save us all... and then we'll drink hot chocolate... with marshmallows!” she explained to the sorcerer, although she was almost sure that they had no marshmallows. The red-haired woman thought for a moment and said smiling strangely sadly.

"Yes, indeed, my friends will certainly not fail to save their friend Scarlet." she said with a strange bitterness in her voice.

“You really talk really weird sometimes.” She muttered under her breath, but the sorcerer heard her and snorted.

"May our friends hurry before we run out of light or something worse finds us here." Scarlett murmured.

"Are you trying to scare me like some kid? I'm Princess Frosta, ruler of the Snow kingdom, even that stupid Horde Ultimate calls me the Dread Ice Bane! I'm not afraid of anything!” She shouted at the woman, who shook her head indulgently.

“If you knew as much of the dark secrets of the universe as I do, you wouldn't be so tough, especially in the ruins of a city built by an ancient race.” She heard the conceited amusement in the sorcerer's voice.

"And how would someone raised by the Horde know anything about such things?" Adora said the cadets didn't even know what a birthday was.” she said, holding her sides and trying to look down at the former member of the Horde, who looked at her with her green eyes.

"Who said I learned all this in the Horde? The universe is old and immeasurable, even Etheria hides dark secrets that the sages of Mystacor never dreamed of... On the other hand, our beautiful planet is a secret built on a secret based on lies mixed with distortion.” Scarlet said philosophically.

"You know, I didn't know Shadow Weaver very well, but I have a feeling she'd sound just like you." She looked sideways at the People's Rebel member, who smiled crookedly.

"I've been hearing it a lot lately, apparently there's something to it."

She winced at the sorcerer's words, then rolled up her sleeve and looked at her watch with the illuminated dial. They'd been here three hours now, and she wondered anxiously when the batteries would run out, when she'd empty her canteen and have to refill it with that stinking cave water, when she'd starve to hunt those terrible birds and toothy frogs...

“No, Catra will definitely not leave me here! She's my friend” she thought, though she wasn't so sure in her heart. Finally, she said some mean words to her, similar to the ones she had said to her at the very end of the war, when she didn't yet know that Cat Girl had joined the rebellion. Then she hit her with an ice fist very hard, and now she was very close to doing it again, having previously allowed Scarlet's magic to paralyze her and thus Lonnie badly injured Netossa's hand. In fact, she was imprisoned here

through her own fault for not helping her friends in the fight, and she is the princess of the elements, the strongest of the invincible eight! “No, that's not true. I've never been a Dread Ice Bane. I'm just a little Frosta that no one remembers. Even my friends have probably forgotten about me." She thought bitterly as tears welled up in her eyes. She glared angrily at Scarlet. "It's your fault too! Yours and your stupid magic, she thought, and now she really wanted to punch her in the stupid red head!” Were it not for the fact that they were trapped here together and both sailed on the same ice floe, she would not fail to do it.

"Why don't we look around instead of standing here like these ice pillars?" she asked the sorcerer, who looked at her in surprise.

“That's a pretty good idea. But aren't you afraid that your friends or my friends will break through this wall and not find us?” Scarlet asked with bored curiosity.

"No, you know how good Catra's sense of smell is, you grew up together! And then there's Melog." she said to the sorceress, who looked a bit confused

“Yes, I remember Catry's sense of smell well, very well ...” said the red-haired woman, and hearing these words she shrugged her shoulders.

So together they set off into the impenetrable dark corridors.

Scarlett felt worse and worse. This place… its aura began to slowly overwhelm her. She felt as if invisible tentacles were entwining her soul and mind. Given where she was, it was highly likely. It could have been some sort of defense system created by the Elder Things to disable enemy sorcerers who dared cast spells in their city. Or maybe it was some astral entity that had broken loose when Entrapta was trying to hack the planet's geomantic web and was prowling the ruins of the ancient city. Though it's equally likely that it was fear. She was afraid that she would be

imprisoned here for daemons knew how long, but also that she would not be able to return to her true, natural form. She didn't know if Lonnie would be willing to risk her life to save her. Scarlet was the only sorcerer the People's Rebellion had, but was that reason enough for anyone to put themselves at risk for her? After all, even the Scarlet that the cadets knew from the Fright Zone wasn't very popular, and Scarlet the Sorceress wasn't very trustworthy... But if Lonnie or anyone saw her in her true form… she loathed it herself, but it was the only thing she didn't feel as if she was walking in a foreign, uncomfortable skin. Once Lonnie learns her true identity, not only will she lose her position in the People's Rebellion, but she will also cease to be of use to Creeping Chaos, so it will have no reason to keep her promise, and the only person who was important to her will remain dead.

There was, of course, a problem with the Ice Princess. The girl radiated hope and blindly believed that her friends would save her… Perhaps she was right. After all, she was the princess and ruler of one of the greatest kingdoms and had a runestone. It was too valuable to just leave it here. On the other hand, even being a princess didn't protect against abandonment, Entrapta knew best.

But the girl will be a problem if she has to assume her true form. Even if he doesn't throw his fists at her, he can tell someone about her secret. So she seriously considered whether she might have to murder the girl. She may have been a brave warrior and princess of the elements, but with a lot of luck and a bit of trickery, she would be able to take Frosta's life... Only she wasn't sure if she could kill her in cold blood. She wasn't a murderer. She had already taken life, and sometimes, but always from an enemy who wanted to hurt her himself. And this girl had done nothing wrong to her, though she and Lonnie had attacked her and her friends. He was a good kid, honest and likeable, who had done nothing wrong in his short life. She would very much not want her dead, and hoped that Creeping Chaos would grant her this favor… though who in their right mind counted on the mercy of the Outer God?

“You think we'll meet these old thing here.” Frosta finally broke silence.

“Old things?” she asked, not following the girl's reasoning.

“You know, those conical things with wings. mean ones.” said the ice princess and snorted.

“Ah, you're talking about the Elder Things.” she said, understanding what the girl was talking about. "It's possible, though personally I'd be more afraid of the Shogoths."

“Who are Shogi?” Frost asked curiously.

“Shogoths are a servant race created by the Elder Beings to serve them as slaves. Many eyes and mouths, tentacles, an amorphous shape, in a word: horror.”

Frost made a sad face.

“But the many-eyed were so poor. Those Old Things enslaved them… It was kind of like the Prime clones… I know you and Lonnie don't like them, but a lot of them are quite nice. Wrong Hordak, Brother Blade, Mateo who works in Brightmoon's pastry shop. Makes delicious Eclairs. You know, maybe if Lonnie tried them ...” the girl explained, until finally Scarlet interrupted her.

“It's Lonnie who doesn't like clones, although I don't know how sincere this feeling is. My personal relationship with them is quite complicated.” she answered both truthfully and very euphemistically.

“Because you know, the clones also did terrible things because Horde Prime told them to. Maybe it was the same with these Shogis, only they just look a little scary, but maybe we are scary for them too? I can be quite scary, and so can Catra. Not to mention the whole Shadow Weaver thing, that one was terrible.”

She gnashed her white, even teeth, irritated by the direction this discussion was taking. She turned to the Ice Princess and growled

sharply.

“You know what? When we meet Shogoth, you tell him that you want to be friends with him, and I'll start running as fast as I can. It will keep me alive and you will be tasty and everyone will be happy, including Shogoth.”

The girl looked at her askance.

“You know, you're different from the other cadets I've met.” she said with surprising thoughtfulness.

“What do you mean”” she asked carefully.

“I mean, I mean I only know Catra, Adora and Scorpia, but even now they don't know about normal things. For example, Catra is very smart, but she didn't know that an engagement is not the same as a wedding. And you seem to know more than most, even the very smart ones. You're like a learned sorcerer from Mystacor, but not as nice as Glimmer’s Papa and Auntie, just as mysterious and a little scary as in the old legends. You're actually a bit like the Shadow Weaver, minus the meanness, the mask, and the Scars.

Be careful girl, your thoughts are going to very dangerous places.

“Believe me, I can be very mean, especially to those who poke their noses into my affairs. she said as coolly as possible, hoping that in this way she would discourage the girl from investigating the truth, but Frosta just shook her head disapprovingly.

Finally, they reached a huge cave, in the middle of which was a large lake. It was so huge that she couldn't see the other shore. There were lots of mushrooms everywhere, and strange things she couldn't name. In the middle of the lake, or at least far from the shore, there was a strange, perfectly round island, reached by a narrow stone bridge. Or rather, a causeway, as if someone had lifted a strip of stones out of the water. However, the most

important thing was what was on the island. It was a mining elevator, similar to the Drill ones, but it was made of crystal, like a structure she had once seen.

“This was built by the First Ones!” she exclaimed happily, but then added. "Though I don't know if we should be happy about it. They weren't as great and nice as we once thought. And that what Catra was saying… You probably didn't hear it… But maybe that's the way out then.” She walked towards the footbridge. Scarlet followed her with a slight hesitation. They were tearing through mushrooms and that weird lichen or whatever they were. She had the uneasy feeling that she was being watched. Strange creatures, like round legless mice with bodies almost like those of worms, buried themselves in the ground as she passed them. She really hated this place. As they got quite close to the stone causeway, she heard a strange scratching sound.

“What was that? she asked in a frightened voice. Scarlet turned and said.

"I think we've got company, and it's definitely not the kind we'd like." murmured the sorcerer. When she looked to the side. her companion was looking at, she saw dozens of these horrible bird-spiders running towards them, but these were bigger, much bigger, almost as big as she was. She created a great ice hammer.

"Are you going to fight them here now?" Scarlett asked incredulously.

“Well, I'm going to!” She replied to the sorcerer, trying to sound as brave as possible. There were just so many monsters , and they were really terrible! As soon as the first one approached her, she hit him with an ice hammer that sent him flying to the opposite wall.

“And that's how it's done.” she shouted, but then Scarlet screamed.

“But you sure don't survive in that way!”

She snorted at such cowardly words and crushed the nearest of the monsters to a bloody pulp, but the spiderbirds began to surround her and one of them shot a tongue at her and hit her cheek. She felt sticky wetness running down her face, and when Scarlet tugged on her arm, she didn't resist. They ran towards the dike. Every now and then she threw ice spikes behind her, knocking down groups of nasty things, but they didn't budge. When they reached the causeway, they had to slow down, Scarlet threw some magic missiles at the monsters and killed several of the creatures. While they were on the footbridge, she covered it with ice and formed an ice wall. They were halfway there when something jumped out of the water and jabbed her in the leg.

"Ouch," she screamed. She saw and saw a large penguin-like bird, but with a toothy jaw, which bit into her calf. The sorcerer threw a magic projectile at him and knocked him down. Then she took her hand, and together they ran to the island, though the pain in her leg was excruciating and tears of suffering filled her eyes. She created another wall of ice and froze the water around her so the water creatures couldn't attack her, while Scarlet walked over to the elevator and tried to start it.

"I told that saber-toothed penguins exist, I hope Catra believed me!" she cried, leaning on her only good leg.

"And did Catra or Adora tell you how to start the First Ones machines? Because if not, we're going to have to stick together."

She felt despair, but with a great effort of will she controlled it. She didn't want to die, especially in such a horrible way, but if she had to, at least let Scarlet save herself.

"You go. I…I'll stay here and try to hold back as long as I can." she called to the sorcerer, feeling the monsters pressing against the barrier she had created.

"Can't you just freeze the whole lake?" Scarlet said in an annoyed voice.

“I... I can't do it. I'm not as strong as the other princesses. I could never do wonderful things like them. I've never had the opportunity to develop my full powers because, you know, ice is just ice. Nothing worth noting. I'm just stupid Frosta, the kid on the throne. I'm just a walking failure.” She said and sniffled.

Scarlet stared at her blankly for a few moments, as if seeing her for the first time, and… she began to undress.

“Scarlett?” she asked confused. “What are you going to do? Do you want to fight them underwater? This is not a good idea!” she called to the red-haired woman, who had already stripped naked and arranged her clothes neatly to the side.

"Scarlet was never particularly physically fit, she would never carry you up the scaffolding to the very top. But her friend is a completely different story.” she said in an almost dead voice and arched back. She began to transform. She had grown taller, two meters tall, and wonderfully muscular. She had gray skin and long gray hair. Her hands were clawed, ears were large and pointed her eyes were solid green, and her face... looked like it was made of cracked porcelain. Her face reminded her of only one long-dead person. She was so scared that she almost fell into the water.

“W-who are you.” she asked, feeling that she was losing control over the ice barrier, while this strange person put on a fur coat and extended her hand to her.

"Who I am is not important right now, let's say I'm a failure to for now.” Said the strange being in a strong and deep voice and added. "Give me your hand and I'll carry you upstairs, but you have to trust me." She extended her hand to her. She hesitated for a moment, then offered her hand to this not-so-stranger.

After a few minutes her companion carried her up on the scaffolding. She must have been really strong because she didn't even get tired. They found themselves in a wide and dark corridor

whose walls were covered with the symbols of the Primes. Everything here was made of the same crystal as the other First buildings. Entrapta once said that the structures of this ancient race had the ability to repair themselves or something. Anyway, everything here looked brand new. But the corridor ended in a lump of ice on one side, as if the glacier itself had shattered it, and the other led to a room, large and wide, in which was a kind of swimming pool. In the block of ice, she saw a woman trapped in the ice. The desiccated corpse of another woman leaned against the wall of the corridor, looking as if she was staring at her companion trapped in the ice. The person she had known as Scarlet burst into a deep, bitter laugh.

"Looks like we'll be joining them here soon, unless we choose to be eaten..." She said in a hopeless voice.

Pain of Heart and Soul

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She watched the fight on the roof, her clawed hands clenched angrily. She knew what Calamity was capable of. Her ward could be cruel in a way beyond imagination, the Grayskull family experienced it firsthand. But what was happening now... Calamity was chasing Captain Moonshadow, smiling madly and singing.

“Swallow: Black dagger, torn from the breast of the wind.” sang the blond-haired creature, and carried out subsequent attacks, which the pirate captain barely avoided. She had no idea what had gotten into Moonshadow's mind… or rather Queen Angela, that she was trying to kill Adora. Apparently, she did not remember the existence of She- Ra , although it must be admitted that even she did not realize the full capabilities of her ... daughter. At any rate, in her infinite poetic meanness, Calamity had decided to take the opportunity to murder Glimmer's mother, and all she could do was watch helplessly through the eyes of her shadows.

“Swallow: Black diamond, thrown here by the devil.” shouted her ward , when she once again cut the pirate's clothes, leaving another bleeding wound. They were standing on the roof of a tall building right now, and Moonshadow had nowhere to run.

“For not knowing the nest, for cursing beauty” she sang the last verse and was getting ready to deal the final blow when suddenly an energy weapon blast hit her knee, and the former queen fired a Solarian flare into the face of the aristocrat. And then she wrapped herself in wings and disappear in a flash of light. Calamity roared in impotent fury as she realized she was left alone in the pouring rain...

But unfortunately, she wasn't alone

“Was it magic?” asked the boy who was hiding during the storm in a booth made of corrugated metal that was placed on the roof. Lady Cala turned to him, the flare scorching half of her face, but the wounds were already healing up at lightning speed.

“Yes, it's a powerful and ancient magic, but you know? I'll show you something just as wonderful” Calamity said , intending to do something terrible. She could do nothing, nothing, if only because of her deal with Nyarlathotep . All she could do was witness his death, which was another crime that weighed on her conscience.

Eti came to her friends before the blonde managed to return, or rather the BLONDE. She hoped that Stinka wouldn't come back, after the shots she'd been inflicted with the winged captain , it would be a miracle if this bitch could walk. Although in her experience the gods usually sided with such bitches, there was little she could do about it.

All her friends were alive and well. Lilka was doing the classic and traditional orc victory dance, or so she called it, which was jumping up and down and shouting random things. Alatar was showing something on his datapad and explaining something to the Sting, and Bina was talking about something with the Veggie , gesticulating chaotically as if she was explaining herself. Something similar was done by the Smarty and Steeleyes only with the commander of the guard. Even the itel looked pleased. Fist knelt worriedly at the Sparkle Hand, which seemed to be frightened. The others acted as if they had triumphed, even though they had lost the great captain Wingy. She turned off the cloaking field and walked over to her friends.

“Where have you been?” Bina asked as soon as she saw her.

“Well, in the city, and where else would I be?” she replied in an innocent voice. Their captain looked at her suspiciously, but then waved her hand away. Paying no attention to her at all, she walked over to Sparkle Hand and asked her.

“Are you all right, Sparky?”

The deaf girl shook her head

“Yes, but when the explosion flashed, I lost my sight for a moment and I was very afraid. It's so stupid to be blind and deaf” the girl said and laughed nervously.

Itel snorted contemptuously.

"If you hadn't been standing like that idiot and staring at Adora... That She-Ra... if you hadn't been staring... You'd be fine." Itel said. Fist and Bina gave her a reproachful look, but the elf made little of it.

“Leave her alone Itel.“ she growl surprisingly sharply at the solarian. Alatar said to Sting "It's complicated" thinking she couldn't hear him, but she got up and turned to Dragonkin and said in an offended tone.

“It's nothing complicated. I like Sparkle Hand. Itel likes me and is jealous of me, and Alatar likes Itel, but he got something like a brush from her... “ when she said that, both girls turned red and Dragonkin straightened his tail in embarrassment. She didn't understand what they meant.

“Yes, it's very complicated. Even more than with Rogelio , Kyle and Lonnie, or with Adora and Ca ...” she did not finish because the thunder struck the not so distant temple. “Jeez, when I throw them, they don't seem so loud.”

“Is she always like this... Luminous and Rainbow, so amazing.” Fist said with reverence. For follower of Iomadae, BLONDE must have looked to her like an incarnation of an Inheritor, an avatar of

the Goddess walking the earth. It must have been a huge shock for her.

“Oh, when she defeated Horde Prime she had much more power.” Perfuma said. The Wrongdak nodded and said with delight, though not with religious fever as with the mercenary .

"She banished Horde Prime from my brother's body and annihilated him... And changed Velvet Glove in a big tree…”

“"That last one sounds strange..." Bina said carefully.

“She is at her strongest when she is with her beloved, Cat ... “ Perfuma began explaining, but did not finish, because BLONDE and Stinkaemerged from between the streams of rain. They both looked shocked and distraught. Though most likely the aristocrat was only pretending. Then she saw what Odor was holding in his hands ...

“Angela... Queen Angela. She... did something terrible.” BLONDE said in a broken voice.

Calamity learned what fear is. No, not fear, but horror. Horror of what might happen when Nyarlathotep finds out how much she has jeopardized his plans. Though most likely the Great Outer God, Creeping Chaos was fully aware of what she had done. Well, chasing Moonshadow wasn't the best idea. She acted on impulse, after all, she hated Glimmer far less than she hated Catra and Adora… Though making her suffer the loss of her mother again was such a tempting prospect.

In fact, she was afraid of She- Ra . She had no idea she had so much power. And with power aimed directly at beings like her. She felt a piercing pain, also for the first time in her life, piercing her wonderful and perfect body as soon as she got close to She-Ra. If she were a worse creature, like those Icari cubs she carried in her arms, she would scream in agony. But the suffering was more

than compensated by the despair of Adora walking beside her, and she had a lot more surprises in store for her, oh yes ...

As she stood in front of everyone and the vile usurper said in a broken voice that "Queen Angela has done something terrible," she stared at the disgusting feline creature that gave her an unseen glare behind her tinted goggles. She knew she had shot her in the leg, and she knew it too, but neither of them could do anything about it, the vile cat out of fear, and she because of the ridiculous deal Shadow Weaver had made with an Outer God.

“What, but... How?” said an twisted woman called Scorpia .

Normally, the way you kill meddling brats, she wanted to yell into that dumb snout, but instead she smiled sadly, as befitted a righteous and concerned aristocrat.

"I fought her on the rooftops, trying to disarm her, but… She grabbed that boy and covered herself with it, then threw him down off the roof and ran away… I wasn't fast enough and couldn't save him." She lowered her eyes and laid the body on the cobblestones. Then suddenly Adora remembered something and walked over to the boy and touched his forehead with her hand

"Once it's worked, maybe it's not too late either." she said, and she shone with a bright and warm light that warms souls, but she felt as if someone had set fire to every cell of her body. It was only with the greatest effort of will that she managed to stop herself from howling in anguish. And then the boy's chest began to move, and his body wasn't so scarred anymore. Everyone, even her, took a deep breath for the sake of it all, but Adora looked exhausted.

“That's amazing even for you.” Scorpia said delightedly. Meanwhile, she experienced a new feeling, another one that day, panic. If the kid says who hurt him... He won't win against She-Ra. Maybe against these two... Although the idiot with the sting was strong and had really great power, so she could be dangerous. However, for all her perfection and unrivaled power

resulting from the gifts of the Key and the Gate and the Creeping Chaos, she would not have the slightest chance against the princess of power. She decided that if she was to die fighting She-Ra, she would kill as many as she could first, let Adora's conscience bear it. First, he'll start with the feline freak

However, when the boy opened his eyes and looked at her, she realized that there was nothing to worry about. He did not recognize her, probably lost his memory as a result of the impact or simply death. From what she'd heard, it was common in these situations. He won't remember what happened for a long time, if ever.

“Only the greatest mystics can bring the dead back to life.” whispered Rechiza in astonishment.

“Do these things happen in yor part of the galaxy?” Perfuma asked incredulously, but Lashunti shook her head.

“Very rarely, except in the Eoxian way” Rechiza explained, and when the three women looked at her without understanding, she added. “You know, necromancy, undead things like that.” she explained.

“Lady Rechiza, this kind of thing was not practiced here.” Wrongdak interjected.

"Unless in the Shadow Weaver fairy tales... She was my... teacher... terrible person, but she's gone now." she sighed and said. "Someone take care of him, and we need to talk about what happened here." said Adora, returning to her natural form, worthy only of sheer contempt.

They stayed under the roof. All but Eti, Dilayla , and partly Adora were soaked, but that could wait. Bina had sent all her wards to their wacky armored personnel carrier, though the spoiled solarian protested. Now they could discuss more important matters.

"Did you know the Queen… Did you know who Captain Moonshadow is?" Adora asked with pain painted on her face, which made her almost attractive.

"I don't know what you mean by '*who Captain Moonshadow is*' and forgive me, but I don't think we know the context..." Bina explained with her arms crossed over her chest. She clearly didn't want to be here, which was hardly surprising.

"Maybe I'll explain it first, before we get to other things, who Captain Moonshadow is, or what you call her, Queen Angela, and what we have in common with her. Captain Moonshadow was a prisoner of the Azlanti Star Empire, a powerful Empire that is based on the Idea of the supremacy of the human species, like me, Adora, Perfuma, Bina, or Rosie…" she said, stretching a few details a bit. Now the happy moment was approaching." she had to describe everything in such a way as to cause as much pain as possible to the vile usurper. "They sent her, for reasons unknown to us, to the prison planet Jadehell, to a labor camp. It's a scary place, where every plant produces some toxic fumes, and fungi spray deadly spores there." She was pleased to see that the Perfuma was slightly green. "Prisoners work there without protective clothing gathering rare plants, and they don't survive there more than a few months, although at the end they are said to pray to all the gods for death." She added some color to the story, for educational purposes, of course. "Such a place will rob the heart of even the noblest person. I wouldn't wish this fate even on my worst enemy. Moonshadow managed to get out of prison, although it cost her damaged lungs and most likely the loss of her arm. She became a ruthless pirate, imprisoning and torturing her enemies. She is merciless and cruel, instilling fear throughout the galaxy. Mr. Arkan Tar can confirm my words because it was from him that I learned all this." She looked meaningfully at Verthani, who coughed nervously and quietly confirmed her words. "Though she was probably a wicked woman by then anyway, because it takes something really awful, like betrayal by those closest to her, to bring her down to that level of wickedness." She shook her head in mock regret. Joyful choirs played in her heart as she saw the spasm of pain on Adora's face,

a little justicefor such a vile thief of destiny. Bina gave her a suspicious look but only shrugged and said.

“I haven't had a bad word to say about her so far. We met on Saltmarsh, it's such a backwater world. She wanted to see Wrongdak there, then offered us protection on the flight here. So far, she has performed well with our agreement. She even saved my kids once. I can't say much about her past. All I know is that she had a husband and a daughter, but she lost them. Well, such experiences will change everyone, and for the worse.”

Wonderfully, though unintentionally, you helped me in my quest for justice, she thought as she saw Adora's face and barely suppressed a joyful smile.

“They are alive. Her daughter is my friend Glimmer, Queen Etheri Brightmoon. And her father is the widower king Mikah ... I mean, not the widower king anymore. Queen Angela... she led the Rebel against the Horde and then there was...a terrible accident that almost killed us...She sacrificed herself for all of us...We thought she was dead and she...is alive, but all that has happened to her is just me wine." She buried her face in her hands and began to cry, Scorpia and Perfume hugged her.

“I… didn't know it was her. I've never seen her before, not even in a photo. She was a bit scary so I never thought it could be Glimmer's mom. If I had known that…" said Wrongdak and almost cried too. *By Shub- Nigurath and Glaaki, is being a crybaby contagious?* she thought with contempt, but also walked over to the woman and put her hand on her shoulder.

"Ehem, I know it's not the best time, but it's time for us.” Arkantar interjected. Verthani adjusted his glasses and continued. "We're not princesses or anything, but we're connected to a pirate who tried to destroy this town and practically murdered a child. Even with your intercession, we may be in serious trouble, at best they will stop our ship for a few weeks.” When he mentioned it, Bina suddenly turned pale. Very interesting. "Anyway, we'd better get out of here quickly. And to Mr. Wrongdak, I also advise you to

join us. They don't like clones here.” he said, and Bina nodded her head.

“Yes, that's a good idea... Let's go!” Bina tugged at the dull clone's shoulder with a hint of panic in her voice.

"But I have to..." Wrongdak said, but Adora looked at everyone with strangely absent eyes.

"I can't stay here either... I was supposed to beware of the shadow of moon and... Catra!" she cried out in fear and transformed into She- Ra again and stuck the blade into the ground. A multicolored light flashed, and she again felt as if someone was burning her alive. When the light disappeared, Adora was no longer here either.

"Oh, that Catra is her fiancée..." Bina laughed and pulled Wrongdak out of the room. The others left as well, leaving Scorpia and Perfume behind .

Itel felt an excruciating pain in her heart as she saw Eti and Rosie talking in sign language. She loved the cat girl, but she couldn't give her what the deaf girl could give her. Joy of life, positive attitude to life, joy and serenity. She pursed her lips tightly and thought. *Okay, so be it. I still have a mission. She's the only one that matters.* And she walked out of the crush unstoppable.

She had to admit that she had perfectly managed to maneuver Bina into sending her to the vehicle. She looked for one of the local interplanetary newscasters. The building was new, but mostly used Prime's technology . She handed the sender the equivalent of two hundred credits in Vescarian coin.

“Broadcast it on the given frequency every eight hours for ten days in the given direction. *Shadow cats welcome. The Treasure is guarded by Skittermander- hearted dragons . But beware of marauding wolves* she commanded. *The Shadows of Tarak will come.*

As soon as Calamity entered the ship, along with the rest of the crew, she ordered her charge to go with her to their room. As soon as the blond woman closed the door, she tried to slap her, but the young woman grabbed her hand in the air, holding it in an iron grip. Calamity wagged her finger and said.

"Be careful my dear, I'm not like one of your wards who you could beat over the head when you weren't in the mood." Her voice was wonderfully clear and gentle.

“Every one of my wards, even Kyle, had more sense than you. In your childish sadism, you have jeopardized the mission.” she snarled , but Calamity just rolled her eyes.

"He's just a dead kid, no big deal, anyway, he's alive thanks to your She- Ra's power. And you shouldn't be following anyone with those your shadows, because, you know, someone might notice.” The girl explained with an indulgent smile.

What Calamity said threw her off balance for a moment, but then she regained it. She- Ra's power must have been immense to defeat Horde Prime , and she knew a great deal about coming back from the dead, after all, and by her own experience. She smiled nastily and spoke in an almost affectionate voice.

"If you've had to kill the kid, and it wasn't necessary because it was enough to intimidate him, at least you could have disposed of the corpse instead of blaming Glimmer’s mother. For her, this is a personal matter and believe me, she will not fail to investigate, and then the truth may come out. Not to mention all your chasing… Fortunately, I'm not the one you have to explain to.” She made a mystical gesture and the whole room was enveloped in darkness. She moved aside so that her ward could see what was in the middle of the room. From the obsidian tabletop rose a dy that slowly formed into the form of Carsai called the King. Calamity fell to her knees, and the figure spoke in a voice that withered the soul.

“We feel so disappointed in you Calamity ...”

Chapter End Notes

I used fragments of Stan Borys Poem The Swallow.

Breaking the Ice

“Alright Entrapta, turn it on!” she called to the inventor, adjusting her makeshift goggles. The stove was tied to a stalactite by a long rope that Lance and George were holding. Entrapta calibrated the device and she operated it. Only Netossa was annoyed because because of her shattered hand, she couldn't help, she just sometimes shouted random orders and generally got mad at everyone. The suspended burner from the converted stove was horribly unwieldy, and she considered asking Entrapta to construct shoes that would allow her to hang from the ceiling. It took them more than three hours to implement the plan, though the most time took them to install the ropes and handles on the ceiling of the cave, to which the ropes that hung it and the converted stove were attached. Entrapta needed no security. After all, she came from Dryll, the largest and most mysterious mountain range in all of Etheria. Though as she watched the purple-haired woman work with absolute concentration, she realized she didn't really know her family's origins. She's never met anyone like her, or even anyone else born in Castle Crypto. Another Etheria secret waiting to be solved, but that's a matter for the future, for now they had more important things on their minds.

Fortunately, they were prepared for a mountain trip, so they took a lot of climbing equipment. Worse with welder uniform, and she could only hope she wasn't getting married wearing dark glasses, though Glimmer said it made her look sexy...

Finally got the machine running and it worked. She melted the ice and saw jets of hot water running down the walls and steam billowing on the ceiling. Gradually, they increased the range of the flames, and great chunks of ice began to break off and thud against the bedrock and walls of the cave.

“Be careful up there!” Netossa yelled as she nearly got crushed by a block of ice bigger than her. However, the work went smoothly,

and though Melog watched everything anxiously with his ears flattened, after a quarter of an hour it was all over and they didn't die in the explosion... although Lance and George were lowering the stove back, it was a bit battered.

“Okay, me and Melog are going to look for Frosta.” Seeing their surprised or, in the case of Netossa, indignant looks, she added. "Netossa has a broken arm, Entrapta will be needed to pilot the Silverwing, and Lance and George, well, you're great librarians, but..." She trailed off meaningfully, and George sighed and said sadly.

“Yes you are right. Find Frosta safe and sound, and look for our sword, it's a treasured family heirloom... And watch out for Lonnie!”

“Better let Lonnie watch out for me.” she said, smiling nastily.

First she bandaged her leg as best she could, then groaned as she fell to the floor.

“We're trapped.” she said with despair in her voice.

"Apparently, though probably not for long. The prospect of becoming hunters now seems far less enticing than before”. said the strange creature sitting down next to no.

"Maybe those creatures downstairs will go away." she asked hopefully.

“Maybe, but it doesn't change much. Sooner or later, such or more terrible monsters will catch us.” said this strange creature.

“And our friends?” she asked, feeling resignation wash over her. Not-anymore-Scarlet laughed bitterly.

"I think it would be better for them if they gave up looking for us, or else they'll be found by something terrible."

She felt a cold sweat trickle down her cheeks. Not only will they die, but they will also take their friends with them. It's almost as if she murdered them herself! She got up and looked around. She needed something to occupy her mind. So she limped over to the desiccated corpse, but the no-no-Scarlet stood up immediately and said a warning.

“Be careful, in such a place they can rise from dead!”

At first she wanted to tell her not to talk nonsense, but she remembered the terrible story Catra had told her and walked to body with the utmost care. After a brief inspection, she spotted a small snowflake hairpin, similar to her runestone. She called the person over and showed him the pin, and the other person laughed hoarsely and said.

“It must have been your predecessor, another Ice Princess. Isn't that ironic. That you will die next to her?”

She listened with one ear. She looked from the desiccated corpse to the body trapped in the ice. She wondered what had happened here, who these women were.

“You know, I think they were friends, or even a couple.” she stated after a moment, and this strange person accompanying her shrugged her shoulders.

“Who can know? You certainly know more about friendship and love than I do.”

She frowned listening to this person and said with surprise in her voice.

“Aren't you Lonnie friends?

“Scarlet and Lonnie spend some qualify time together, but that's it. I've never had a friend or anyone close to me, except maybe one, but she died during the occupation.” Said creature.

She immediately felt a surge of sympathy for this unfortunate creature.

“I'm so sorry for your loss...”

The person looked at her and waved her hand

“It's not your fault. What happened is done.”

"Actually, how am I supposed to address you?" Because I think we're going to spend some time together here, and it could be quite embarrassing.

The person stared at her for a while, considering her answer, and finally said.

"I shouldn't be telling you this, but since we're going to die anyway, you can call me Nightgale and I use the pronouns She/ Her ." She offered her clawed hand. She smiled at her and squeezed her hand.

“Nice to meet you Nightgale ... You know, you look quite familiar, as if someone mixed Hordak with Shadow Weaver... Hyyy . Are you their daughter? Does Entrapta know about you? Or Hordak? And how did they do you? It must have been really awful though.” She was talking to the stunned woman.

“I'm not their child. Not in that sense, anyway… Hordak crossed his DNA with Shadow Weaver after banishing Catra to the Crimson Wastes to be his new right- hand… But he banished me when he knew Horde Prime would arrive. He called it a failure, an abomination Entrapta and Shadow Weaver never knew about me, but it didn't matter. I'm living Scarlet's life, and it's a really good life. Better not to think about Nightgale as she never existed.” The sorcerer said in a depressed voice.

She really felt sorry for the poor woman. She couldn't imagine what it was like to hide in someone else's skin all her life. To be lonely, rejected by the whole world and knowing that when others find out the truth, they will hate you. Even her own father

disowned her. "I'll find you, Hordak, and I'll punch that stupid head of yours" she thought, flushing with anger, and said to her companion when she had calmed down a bit.

"You know, you're quite pretty, and also very strong and very athletic, and you're a sorcerer, which means you can use your own magic as if you were your own runestone." You have nothing to be ashamed of. Tell Lonnie, Kyle, and that lizard… Rogelio . They will definitely accept you!" She was absolutely sure of what she said. Nightgale smiled sadly.

"If only anything in life were that simple." said the sorcerer gloomily. – In my veins flows the blood of two people most hated by the cadets. Besides, I tricked them all, especially Lonnie. She's not one to forgive easily."

She thought for a moment and said with delight.

"Then you can come to us. You don't have to meet Hordak , but you'll meet your half-sister, she's so sweet, and Entrapta will be a wonderful stepmother... And actually Catra and Adora are your stepsisters too, and all the clones are your uncles. You have a huge family, you're not lonely."

This time Nightgale burst into laughter, genuine and loud, echoing throughout the room.

"Oh Frosta , no one has made me laugh so much in a long time." Nobody since…" She looked sad for a moment, but then she smiled again and said. "I will consider your offer." Now why don't we search this place, because seriously, it's stupid to die here.

So they looked around this place. Nightgale stated that the ancestor of the Ice Princess must have died of blood loss, judging by the wounds she received and judging by the small picture pendant, her name was either Elsa or Anna. They found nothing else interesting, except for a strange pink crystal, which she decided to give to the sorcerer, who did not own any jewelry. In

the second room there was this big pool, but the most interesting thing was the crystal hanging from the ceiling, it sparkled with multicolored light. For a moment she wondered why she had the feeling that she had seen him somewhere before. Only after a few moments did she understand what he really was.

"It's the same crystal those nasty Old Things used to enslave the many-eyes!" she exclaimed indignantly.

“Apparently the First ones were also interested in this technology.” Nightgale said anxiously looking at the pool and the walls in it.

"Because the First ones liked to do terrible things and they loved crystal objects… though it looks more like a rainbow icicle. I know much about ice ...” she explained to her new friend.

And then a red light flashed and a woman's, though rather artificial-sounding, voice was heard.

“Attention! Intruder detected! Activation of defense systems. Summon a Cleansing Bioroid to activate combat functions.”

“I did not do anything!” she called, and summoned ice fists.

“Me neither!” cried the sorceress in a voice full of horror.

And then the pool began to fill up. At first she thought it was mud, but then it became a great gooey creature with dozens of eyes and mouths. It also had great tentacles, thicker than the branches of a tree.

“Shogoth.” whispered Nightgale in absolute horror.

“Many-eyes!” She exclaimed happily.

Several eyes looked at her, but most were directed at the crystal or icicle.

“So we're going to die.” said the sorcerer resignedly. But she looked at the crystal and smiled triumphantly.

“Not at all. I have a plan.” she said, and limped to the edge of the pool.

- Hi, I'm Princess Frost. She waved a friendly hand to the multi-eyes . “I wanted to ask you for help, but I will help you too. I'm a friend of She- Ra'a , you know, that huge light woman. You remember her? She was good to you. She set you free. I know those mean cronies enslaved you, as did the Primes, but you know what? I'll set you free, and you'll help me get back to my friends. And then maybe we'll be friends! she said to Wieloeye and, despite Nightgale's protests , she threw ice bullets at the crystal, smashing it into tiny pieces. There was a roar…

“What do you see there, Kyle?” shouted Lonnie, her voice indistinct from her wounds.

“For now, I see darkness, I see darkness.” he replied to his commander and girlfriend at the same time. He heard the angry growl of the General's Companion.

“That's I can see! Would you look around?” The woman yelled, and he hastily obeyed. He squeezed through a narrow corridor full of slimy Mushrooms and clumsy spiders or crabs, he wasn't sure what these creatures were, but they reminded him too much of their new cosmic friends. He volunteered here, only he or an imp could get in here, even Dr. Moors would have problems here, though maybe that's just what he said. He didn't like, and to be honest, he was a little afraid of a brain in a cilinder. He didn't want Imp to put himself at risk, and he felt he should somehow make amends for his failure in their last fight. He never liked to fight, but he was the reason Lonnie got hurt. He didn't take the strange weapon from Mi-Go with him, because he preferred to keep his hands free, and besides, he thought it was quite disgusting, so he only took the sword that they had taken from these two strange men . He liked the weapon very much, it was covered with strange glowing writing that he could somehow read. The inscription read "Sword of Power ". A strange name for a sword,

but whatever swords were called, he never had one, never even held one. Hordak supposedly considered fencing weapons worthy of primitive savages or something, and they had no real lessons in swordsmanship. But if Adora could do it and even became a hero of the galaxy after only training with a staff, he had no such ambitions.

He was finally on the other side of the tunnel, came out covered in dirty slime and cobwebs, but at least he wasn't bitten. He stretched his bones contentedly and was about to shout to Lonnie that it was all right when he felt a hand on his shoulder and heard a familiar voice.

“Hey Kyle”

Catra looking at him seriously. Something growled behind him . He glanced in that direction. This strange and half-transparent magical cat was glaring at him.

“Oh, hey Catra.” He said with a friendly smile. He hoped the former cadet didn't resent him for the recent fight and for shooting at her.

“Kyle! Is there someone with you? Lonnie asked, but Catra motioned for him to keep quiet. He wasn't going to call Lonnie anyway, he'd want her to come down here and get stuck, or worse, come here and start fighting Catra, and that would end up really bad.

“No, I just got scared of something. he said, knowing that this explanation would sound plausible.” Catra motioned for him to follow her. After a while they found themselves in a large room of blue stone, covered with these strange star inscriptions proclaiming that this is the local terminal of the Planetary Archives Heart Gift .

“I hate the ruins of the First ones.” said his old friend from the Fright Zone.

These are the inscriptions of the First ones he thought in surprise, but Catra turned to him.

"What are you doing here?"

He threw up his arms.

“I'm helping look for Scarlet. She's our friend after all.” He explained in a slightly saddened tone. Catra nodded and said.

“And I Frosta, but I only found you, but it wasn't difficult at all. Squeezing through that shaft, you groaned and moaned so much that you sounded like you were being born again.” He blushed in embarrassment, but Catra smiled kindly at him and added. “They're both alive. I sensed by the smell that they were here, but they have gone somewhere and now I am looking for them.

He felt an overwhelming relief fill him. He was glad Scarlet was alive, but he didn't want anything bad to happen to Frosta either, though he was afraid of her. He wiped the sweat from his forehead and rested his hand against the wall. Only now did he notice that there was a hand reader or something. A blue light flashed and a woman's voice rang out.

“Administrator detected.” she spoke, and suddenly a hologram materialized in front of them. It showed a girl his age or a little younger with a short ponytail and wearing a formal dress who smiled at them and said.

“Hi, I'm Planetary Archives Heart Gift. May I help you.”

When this strange hologram appeared, although he thought it looked quite nice, Catra suddenly bristled, her tail became fluffy, and a growl escaped from her throat. Magical Cat turned red. Seeing this, he drew his sword, and then a red light flashed and the voice said.

“Attention! Intruder detected! Activation of defense systems. Summon a Cleansing Bioroid to activate combat functions.”

“What happened?” he asked in a scared voice.

"As always, the First One's damn AI is after me. Run away!” Catra called, dragging him behind her. Heart Gift's saddened gaze drove them away.

She's forgotten what it's like to fight together with Kyle ... Doing anything with Kyle together. The blond-haired former cadet keeps tripping, so she had to hold him up all the time, instead of running on all fours limbs or riding Melog, and they would have escaped without a problem. She considered putting Kyle on her companion's back, but he would most likely fall immediately.

“Catra, what exactly are we running from?” her old friend asked as she helped him up again.

“Spiders Kyle. Giant murderous mechanical spiders.” she said sharply, hoping to scare him and make him run faster.

The blond looked around in surprise.

“But there are no spiders here ...” he said...

She was about to tell him to stop asking stupid questions, but then she heard a loud buzzing sound.

“Aren't they giant mosquitoes?” Kyle asked anxiously.

“Mosquitos?” she asked unconsciously, and Melog flattened his ears.

“You know, blood-sucking flies. explained the blonde.

“I know what Kyle's Mosquitoes are!” she snapped at him, wondering how often Lonnie wanted to murder him.

“Good thing they aren’t bees. Lonnie is allergic to bee venom.” Kyle wondered

Constantly she thought, but didn't even comment on what her friend had said. They continued running ahead, but the attackers were just coming, they really looked like metal mosquitoes with huge crystal eyes of red color. Their stings were sharp as spears, but some green liquid was dripping from them, so it was probably poisonous. Wonderfully. The first one flew to them, but then she jumped on him and shattered his eyes. But more were coming, hundreds of them. She wondered where I should run to. It would be easiest if she went back to her friends, but then she would expose them to the attack of these monsters. The mosquitoes attacked them constantly, and she and Melog, red with anger, destroyed them one by one, but they kept coming. As she made another dodge, she stumbled and fell painfully to the ground, and the three monsters were about to impale her through when Kyle slashed with his sword, cutting all three in half. She looked at him in disbelief. Only one weapon could do such a thing, but that was only Kyle .

"You have this power…" she said cautiously, but Melog gratefully brushed against him. However, they had lost some precious moments now, and the monsters were closing in on them more and more. It was bad, very bad, and she knew they couldn't count on anyone to save them because they were the rescue team themselves.

Then they heard a great rumble, as if a large amount of something heavy was rolling through the cave. A huge amorphous shape emerged from the darkness. It mainly consists of fodder, eyes and tentacles that captured these terrible mosquitoes. After a while, they were all destroyed... Only now they faced a much more terrifying one.

“It's Shogoth!” said Kyle , who was terrified, but then she heard Frosty's absolutely indignant voice .

“It's not Shogi, it 's Many-eyes!” she cried, and the giant monster lifted the tentacle in which it gently held the Ice Princess.

“How do you like my new friend?” she exclaimed proudly

Part three - Planet of secrets -Sorrowflame

The battle began suddenly.

Taurus was the most industrialized planet ruled by clones still loyal to their dead ruler, not his heirs or rebels. They were alone, so they were an easy target, and most importantly, very valuable, because there was a shipyard there. That's why he chose it as the first target... of a stabilization mission. The enemy didn't have much forces here, just four standard Galactic Horde cruisers. To this you had to add twice as many ships of the destroyer rank and a few smaller ships controlled by simple AI. The main problem was that the enemy ships had a lot of firepower, and the Fearless Armada couldn't afford to loses, not at this stage of the war ... It mean stabilization missions.

The first shot belonged to the battleship Glory of the Fallen, whose accurate shot from her main weapon, a powerful particle beam capable of conducting orbital bombardments, may have decided the outcome of the engagement. He took the shields off the first cruiser, and the plasma cannon and antimatter missiles damaged it badly enough to put it out of combat. Necessary Measures, the Hellknight Cruiser led the attack on the next one and, along with the cruisers Goldsun and Silvermoon , caused it to burst into flames, mainly due to the hellfire torpedoes. At that time, the spacecraft carriers launched fighters that intercepted enemy drones. The combat was fierce, the Horde Fleet lacking coordination but making up for it with firepower. He couldn't afford to prolong the fight unnecessarily, but that's why he prepared a plan. Invincible and the torpedo ships took cover in the shadow of the moon and caught up with the enemy from behind, where he had deployed most of his shield energy to cover the front. They fired a volley of torpedoes and shells. When he saw on the holographic display that the last enemy cruiser was

destroyedin a nuclear explosion, he almost smiled, for he had won his first victory, but it was only the beginning and his situation had become much more complicated.

The occupation of the shipyard was a mere formality. The planetary invasion was much more challenging. Taurus had a single mountainous supercontinent , inhabited mainly by relatives of the Nuar and Ghorans , who apparently simultaneously colonized the planet thousands of years ago. There had been an uprising on the planet since the fall of Prime, and the Loyalists now controlled only a relatively small but highly industrialized region, where more than half the population lived. The main rebel advance was held back mainly by the threat of orbital bombardment. Now, however, with the fleet annihilated and the promise of support from the Fearless Armada, they struck furiously at a long-hated enemy, and Lord Admiral Antares was not one to stand between a furious warrior and the object of his hatred. They had better die instead of his soldiers, their lives were more important. The Fearless Armada took over the capital. Dropships came down from orbit, shielded by orbital fire and fighters. The fight was fierce and the opponent, at least as far as the clones were concerned, was highly trained, but they couldn't coordinate their efforts without their Big Brother's supervision, so they just cleared building after building. The first assault was led by soldiers from Veskarium , firmly convinced that it was an honor, he had no intention of dissuading them of their error. He also sent riffraff under Lady Ka to conquer better fortified places that were away from more densely populated areas. Losses among them could always be easily replenished, and the machine guns standing behind them were great for morale.

In the second assault, after taking the bridgehead, he participated alone, Together with his Star Orphans, and was joined by the Lady of Blades, with her HellKnights. He loved being in the heat of battle, only then could he give vent to the emotions dormant in his heart, could ignite the cold flame that burned in his soul. His soldiers loved him for it. But this time everyone fought with double ferocity. The former exiles of Tarak this time did not wage a pointless and endless war with the swarm, nor did they clash

with the armies of one warlord for another warlord. This time they were fighting for their future, for their home.

The fighting lasted three days and the help of local insurgent forces made the task much easier. Only the citadel towering on the former holy mountain remained unconquered, but that was a matter of the near future, for now he had to discuss more important matters with his allies. It was evening, though it was still too bright for Lady Sorrowflame and she had to shield herself with a shader field . They were in a park full of small trees and bushes, near a picturesque lake. Apparently, the park was previously privately owned by Horde Prime, and only he was allowed here. For a demented dictator, he had a surprising fondness for idyllic landscapes. It might not have been the safest place, but he always liked taking risks, within reason of course. Lady Ka and Lady Sorrowflame were here , as well as Commander Reese , who was injured in a space battle. There was, of course, Asindesa di Vir, who as always gave the impression that she would rather be somewhere else, probably on the battlefield. Veskarium was represented by a huge Veska named Zare , whose face was scarred from burns. The pact worlds were represented by the silver dragonkin, Tarel , who showed some reluctance towards him, although her masters ordered her to cooperate closely with his armada.

“What losses?” He turned to Lady Ka

“Glory of the Fallen and Goldsun suffered some damage, we also lost two fighters and two support ships. The losses among the land forces are five hundred soldiers and eight hundred of my niceties, butit is no loss, new ones will be recruited soon. All in all it went fucking great.” the woman giggled. Zare looked at her with the utmost contempt and drawled.

“A wise commander is not fooled by early victories caused by the enemy's unpreparedness, for it can easily lead to a fall.”

He nodded appreciatively.

“Indeed, we must not get carried away with a feeling of triumph and consider victory a foregone conclusion.” he said thoughtfully. “That's why I chose this planet. We will not only gain an economic base here, but we also eliminated an enemy who was considered an enemy by all factions present in the region, so theoretically everyone sees us as potential allies, so we have some room for maneuver. The only question is who will we ally with now.”

“The natural ally seems to be this Etheria. Although it is said to be a chaotic and disorderly place, its inhabitants seem to be the most willing to help. And they have She- Ra'a, the demigod who annihilated Horde Prime” Asindesa di Vir said in an uncharacteristically friendly tone.

Veska snorted.

“Let me remind you that it was because of what the inhabitants of this planet did that this expedition was organized. They had tried to destroy Veskarium once before in a cowardly and dishonorable way. Besides, we know that the entire war fleet they have are captured ships of the Horde. Horde Ultimate has brought order to his empire and is trying to reform his army. It's always wise to ally with the strongest player.” she said in a voice that held the typical Veskarian arrogance. Not long ago he would have considered her words, but now everything has changed. The whole thing just got a lot more personal.

"When you ally with the stronger, it's like voluntarily acknowledging their superiority." He looked at Zare , on whom very consciously chosen words had the intended effect. “If I have to choose between a warlord or fanatics, I will choose a warlord, but if I can choose, I will choose a hero.” he said in a hard voice and saw Commander Resee smiling proudly at his commander. "Which doesn't mean we won't make a pact with these Horde Ultimate . But first we must consolidate our position and get rid of our Heavenly Brothers.”

Everyone nodded their heads in recognition of this consensus. However, Tarel asked suspiciously.

“But what about this planet? I take it we won't leave her alone?”

He looked at her with searching eyes, trying to see through her intentions, and spoke in a serious voice.

"The interim government we have set up will take over the responsibility of managing the planet and supporting the war effort.”

The dragonkin fluttered its wings nervously with undisguised indignation.

"I guess the locals should be allowed to choose their own government after so many years of occupation, don't you think?"

He shook his head sadly.

“Unfortunately, after ... a quarter of a century of occupation, and so brutal, the basic state institutions have disappeared here and the locals need time to recreate them. You must also consider that the local rebel groups may have trouble coming to an agreement and a civil war is about to break out here, and these are the most brutal of all.” he explained to his companions, but the dragonkin bared her fangs in a mocking smile.

“You know it best. she pointed out to him, but he answered her without showing any resentment.

"Indeed, I know more about this than any of you, and therefore I would not like anything like that to happen to Taurus. After that, it's about more prosaic matters. We need the industry of this planet and its inhabitants to carry out this operation. We cannot allow local conflicts and vested interests and the cries of defeatists to stand in our way.” he explained, and Zare supported him. Tarel looked at him long and finally asked.

“And what do you think the task we have to do.”

“We have the most important task of all. To win.” Lord Admiral Antares said, almost smiling.

The council continued for half an hour, during which they discussed the most important matters, at least officially, and when everything was discussed they went to their quarters, but the Lord Admiral ordered them, her and Lady Sorrowflame, to stay here. She looked at the statue of Horde Prime standing on the pedestal and smiling crookedly said.

"For a guy who talked so much about his own perfection, he had a fucking asymmetrical face, don't you think, boss?" she asked, barely refraining from touching the mask.

“It is characteristic of fallen tyrants not to see their own mistakes and their hypocrisy.” Antares said in a serious tone. She laughed briefly.

“As has already been said today, you know something about it.” she said in a sarcastic tone.

“There is a difference between a strict but fair leader and an insane tyrant.” said the Lord Admiral sharply.

Just semantic, she thought, but said with a shrug.

“ The truest of the hellknights is eager to reach Etheria. My sixth sense tells me that she wants to meet the beautiful Lady Cala or her bitter teacher as soon as possible. I'd bet on the latter, because they both act like they have sticks in asses.”

“It's interesting and may be useful someday. These types of individuals usually have trouble reconciling their mission and their own feelings.” he said thoughtfully.

"I expected you to drop everything yourself and fly to Etheria after all the news you've received." she said cautiously, and her commander thought for a long time about his answer, until finally he spoke in a tone full of thought, such as she had never heard from him.

“I have time... Now I have time my dear Left Hand. But I'll be going there soon, as soon as things settle down here. I can't be late for the big day. You're coming with me too, I'd rather have you with me.”

She pursed her lips angrily, understanding the ambiguity behind his words, but kept silent and instead took out a briefcase full of documents.

“We still have an issue. Capturing the Citadel. It is heavily defended, and underground there are huge resources that will allow us to defend ourselves for many months, and which will be useful to us. “She said and pulled out another sheet and continued. “We have the following options. Orbital bombardment may be the easiest, but there's a good chance you'll destroy parts of the city with missed hits.” she said, the Lord Admiral grimacing in irritation.

“This would complicate our plans and spoil relations with the locals. This idea should be rejected.”

She nodded and said.

“The siege will take us several months, especially if we want to minimize losses, but it will also be expensive. The assault is the fastest, but we will also suffer the greatest losses during it, perhaps up to five hundred soldiers, although we will then take over the most resources gathered there. Perhaps the best approach is to gradually infiltrate during the siege, although this will require intelligence gathering.”

Her commander grimaced and sighed heavily.

"If necessary…" he continued, but Lady Sorrowflame spoke up for the first time that day

“I will take care of this. she said, and when they both looked at her in surprise.” she continued. "As soon as dusk falls, I will take this fortress for you, my lord. We will demonstrate the power of the old days to this place and, by the way, we will test the Dread

Walkers and Colossi of Horror. I owe you for not being able to serve you properly during the uprising. In return, I have only one request from you… Take me with you to this Etheria when you go there.”

The Lord Admiral thought only for a moment, then answered him.

"All right, if you do it during this the night... But you'll be incognito there . "

“It's even better.” Said the red-haired woman and in a smile bared two fangs, as if made of black crystal, too long for a human.

"I tell you, there is no finer man than the Lord Admiral, and he is so incredibly handsome!" Shiren girl exclaimed Ashurk with delight in his voice. The strange Insectoid was dressed in a short skirt and had colorful ribbons attached to her antennae. She was incredibly talkative and raved about absolutely everything, and she was constantly checking her datapad , which she called Cunnyphone. She'd joined them recently and was getting more and more annoying to Tallstar, who was slowly considering knocking her out and leaving her in a diner full of celebrating soldiers, where she would be safe, then telling her she'd been hit by a falling meteor. She was sure she'll believe them.

They were in Angus, the capital of Taurus. They had never been to this planet before, it was too well protected by the fleet. Glimmer assured that it would be the first place they would liberate after the pact creating a galactic rebellion was signed and a joint fleet could be established. However, it need time... Or a Research and Exploration fleet. They'd only been members for a week, and already they were in a victorious battle, and though they were, perhaps that was too much to say. They waited in the transports with the rest of the deep reserve troops, but she was still impressed. Her brother had complained that they weren't allowed to fight, but she was almost content… almost, because several things that were happening around her made her uneasy.

Jewelstar said he was getting paranoid, and Starla said she just couldn't be happy, but she'd saved them all too often with her instincts not to trust him this time.

But she had to admit that there were advantages to serving in the Research and Exploration Fleet. She smiled clenching her fist. Almost immediately after joining the Fleet, she received her new wonderful prosthetics. They were lighter and stronger, and more importantly, they did not jam or hang on the launcher lines erratically. But the most wonderful thing was that she regained full feeling. Again, she could feel the texture of bread, the warmth of a cup of tea, the feel of someone's skin under her fingers... she wished a little that nice mercenary was here, because the inhabitants of the planet did not match her species preferences, but there were many beautiful women in the Research and Exploration Fleet. Maybe she'd help her sister find a boyfriend, but Starla was a romantic and wasn't content with the short-term relationships the mercenaries expected.

As a long-time rebel, she wasn't surprised by how complicated Fleet relations were. There were a lot of groups here who disliked each other but were able to work together to achieve this astonishingly quick victory. There was more species, ethnicity, and culture here than even on Etheria. She had learned the complexity of the social relations that prevailed in the Galaxy, and which this army was a reflection of.

There were conflicts here on many levels. The first was between the mercenaries who had been in Antares' service for many years and those who had been sent here by the governments of the two great powers in the galaxy. The soldiers or mercenaries serving the Lord Admiral were close to each other. Some, the oldest ones, came from Tarak , Lord Admiral's planet, and others were descendants of those who had fled from there. Supposedly there was some kind of war there, and wicked opponents drove out their leader and all the citizens fighting for freedom, though at this point the whole story was getting muddy and unclear. Others joined the Fearless Armada, as they called it, during the thirty years of war it fought, most notably against the Swarm, which

was a fearsome enemy said to be the bane of the galaxy. Many were war orphans or those who joined the Armada to defend the galaxy from this terrible threat. But the rest were lured here by dreams of glory and wealth. She had met many mercenaries in her life, but never one who could afford to hire her own private mercenary army, but in the end the universe turned out to be much bigger than she ever imagined…

However, the other participants of this expedition did not appreciate the presence of their new commander, precisely because of his mercenary background. Professional soldiers looked down on those who sold their services for money, though they also despised each other. They came from the two great powers of the galaxy: the Pact Worlds and Veskarium . The former were very diverse in every respect and more friendly and open. Veskarium 's soldiers were mostly Veskas, huge lizards for whom dying in battle was a dream come true. They scared her a bit, she had to admit, especially since their interpretation of Honor was… controversial. Besides these, there were felines, though more animal than Catra, named Pahtra , and Skittermanders, the same species that took care of Wrong Hordak They were kind and helpful, but in such a way that her head hurt from being around them.

But what they all had in common was contempt for those led by Lady Ka. They were supposedly criminals of various kinds, recruited from the prisons or slums of all the planets the Fearless Armada frequented Lady Ka commanded them with an iron fist and apparently sometimes shoot to them. Used them as cannon fodder and sent them into the hardest fight, but supposedly they had the right to keep everything they raked, as long as they give their commander's share.

But they weren't Tallstar's greatest concern . She had the feeling that there was an aura of mystery surrounding them. From what they understood, no one in the galaxy was aware of the existence of Horde Prime , and many thought that the Swarm was on the prowl here in the Ravaged Zone, as the Empire was known. When it turned out that it was "only" a mad Tyrant, almost everyone

breathed a sigh of relief. She bitterly stated that if they had come here when Horde Prime was still alive, they would have talked differently, they would have regretted ever knowing his name. Of course, many were shocked to see planets whose inhabitants were slaughtered. Many had tears in their eyes. Many sympathized with them, especially when they found out what happened to their family. Sometimes they were even admired for their long struggle with such a powerful enemy. but no one understood anything. No one quite knew the reason for this expedition, but everyone was convinced that it was about some great threat lurking in the zone.

And then there was the Starstone that the Lord Admiral had been asking them about. Everyone, even the Veskas, spoke of him with almost reverence. It was said to be the most powerful artifact in the galaxy. It was located at the center of the giant Absalom Station and enabled the use of Drift Drive, thanks to which it was possible to travel across the galaxy at lightning speed. Some said that this artifact, in ancient times, allowed mortals to become gods, though she was skeptical of such words, for she had never believed in the existence of gods. But there was something else, apparently there was another similar artifact somewhere around here. She had serious suspicions about where he might be, and that made her uneasy.

Now they were at the top of the observation deck of one of the skyscrapers. It was empty because it was near the citadel, the Horde's last stronghold, and many feared that the clones might retaliate by shelling the city, and that would be their first target, though she doubted they would, as they had previously avoided destroying the city, probably because of Big Brother's old orders. Fear, however, did not prevent the inhabitants of Angus from celebrating the liberation in the streets . Probably moonshiners, who will be able to sell their goods openly for the first time in years, will earn a real fortune. There were bursts of fireworks in the sky, as well as images of magically created illusory mystical creatures straight from legend. She had to admit that the Lord Admiral knew how to celebrate a victory.

"It's a pity we didn't meet any of the Ghoran here. They are so kawai. I would take many pictures with them. Can we look for them? My subscribers on Atrax will be delighted.

She looked at Shiren girl wondering if she was that stupid or just pretending, and her brother replied in a grim voice

“The Flores, as they were called here, aroused the extreme reluctance of Horde Prime , as he suspected them of having a collective consciousness, so he had them slowly exterminated until he found them quite tasty, then ordered the purges to stop, only ordered the local population every year elect a thousand representatives to celebrate the annual conquest banquet.”

“Oh, that's great!” Ashurk exclaimed in delight, but her brother rubbed his forehead and explained with absolute calmness.

“He invited them as a main course...”

Shirren antennae first dropped in horror, then rose in delight.

“Oh, the oppressed people, who I helped liberate! You can't even imagine how many likes I'll get when I post videos with them!” she said in an excited voice . Tallstar felt her eyelid twitch. Even the very positive Starla was…confused.

“You must come from a very unusual place.” she said slowly, but Ashurk ran over to them and started talking, showing her pictures on her Datapad .

“Atrax is a wonderful place! Look!” she said with delight.

Talstar rolled her eyes. Most of the photos showed a gloomy industrial city with virtually no sun. She was unfamiliar with the Shirren, few Insectoids can be found in the Empire. Horde Prime was particularly ferocious about these types of creatures, probably fearing their collective consciousness, but Ashurk rather looked like someone who liked things shiny and colorful… But one of the photos caught her attention.

"Wait..." She said commandingly. Shirenka did as instructed and Tallstar and her siblings saw an image of a cat girl. For a moment she thought it was Catra, but then they realized she was younger, twelve or thirteen, with dark brown hair that was straighter than their friend's, and her eyes were gold with blue flecks. She was lying in a hospital bed, and was glaring at the person taking the picture, as if she wanted to hurt him. But what caught their eye the most was the hand. It was metal, with no moving parts. She had recently seen such a prosthesis.

“What was her name?” she asked carefully.

“Teti or something like that, but it doesn't matter at all, because she's mean. After all, a cat girl is supposed to be sweet and adorable, and this cat pounced on me and threatened to rip my antennae out and poke my brain out through my eyes, and all I wanted was to cuddle and take some cute pics. Shirren gir shouted in a voice full of holy indignation.

"Cat girls don't like to be seen as cute and adorable and VERY value their personal space," said Jewelstar, looking down at the insectoid and Tallstar she tried to recover from the shock. *So we missed... who exactly?* she thought, not understanding what she had just seen. But before she could analyze everything, Starla called her.

“Look! She pointed to the river below the citadel. As she put the binoculars to her eyes, she saw an attractive woman with fiery red hair, whom she recognized as Lady Sorrowflame . The woman took off her robes and began to transform. Her body was torn apart and grew, then reassembled into something this corner of the universe hadn't seen in thousands of years. A dragon stood there, not as small and humanoid as Alatar. It was a gigantic red-colored monstrosity, capable of swallowing any one of them whole. And so another legend returned to their world, but this time it was one of those legends you dream of in nightmares... There was a roar that chilled hearts and souls, and the dragon spread its wings and took off into the air. As it circled over the city, casting its dark shadow over it, she saw that its belly was

covered with armor plates. Even legends have to adapt to a new world. Then he sped towards the citadel. She felt sorry for the clones.

Lady Sorrowflame felt the great terror she spread around her. Where her terrible shadow fell, the cries of joy fell silent, and she felt the horror that embraced the mortals here. They had reason to be afraid of her. She was once known as Ashaq The Annihilator and she was able to destroy a city during time, when she was alive . Now she was one of the oldest and most powerful beings in the galaxy and was able to destroy armies and tear apart space battleships. But the inhabitants of this city could feel safe, at least today. It was not against them that she intended to direct her fury. Horde Prime's spawn will taste the horror of days gone by, for doom was coming , an avatar of death itself was approaching .

However, she was not alone, she was accompanied by the Dread Walkers and the terrible Colossi of Horror. The wonderful creations of Necrotechnics , its most perfect creations. Her monster children. They were all covered in gold and red armor that hid their monstrous nature. Dread Walkers were armed with metal claws capable of cutting even steel armor.

In addition, they were poisoned with a venom that acted similarly to Ghoul poison, which paralyzed victims. They were fast and deadly in combat, and it took great firepower to knock them down. While they battled the swarm hordes, they wreaked havoc on his ranks. Their production was not expensive, although in her case it was quite time-consuming, because it did not allow the process to be automated. Things were different with the Colossi of Horror. It was difficult to obtain bodies of the right size. They were four meters high and their armor was stronger than that of tanks. She carried out many cyber and necrotechnical modifications that increased their physical capabilities to an unprecedented level. They also had self-healing systems, because creating them was so difficult. They were armed with flaming morningstars or crionic axes, and all had shields. Only a few were armed with electric

halberds. Each of them also had one eye that shot deadly beams of radiation. Although they were undead monsters, in their beautiful armor they resembled great knights created to fight evil. They were like the entire Fearless Armada. Noble decorations hiding the dark interior. Dread Walker and Colossi of Horror were dropped from the air. When they fell, they curled up into a ball, so they were not injured.

However, she herself was also the work of a necrotechnics genius . Though she didn't remember it due to the Gap, she has undergone many modifications . The implants made her fitter than any dragon. Her scales, especially her belly, have been replaced with pure adamantium carapace . Her claws were also made of this metal. Fangs, in turn, created Voidglass. She was something a hundred times more perfect than that demented buffoon of Horde Prime , though she brought darkness instead of light.

She glided over the city shrouded in shadow, her body surrounded by a personal energy shield. Her dead troops went on the attack. Then she herself began to descend. As soon as the clones detected her, they began firing, but while the Horde's weapons had terrible power, they were inaccurate, so they easily dodged the shots. It flew over the largest cannon and allowed itself to be hit. The beam pierced her shield, but adamantium stopped the beam. Then she opened her jaws and breathed out the black flame of decay, from which she derived her name, Sorrowflame . Necrotic energy penetrated the shield and armor, disintegrating metal and flesh. Then she dug her claws into the walls of the citadel and began tearing them apart, and when it was done she burst inside the building.

It was breaking through the interior of the building, followed by its creations, spreading death and destruction. It devoured enemies whole, absorbing their life energy. She knew it wouldn’t satiate her hunger, nothing could do that, but it didn't matter now, for she was filled with dragon fury. Even the fearless clones fled in panic as the necrotech monsters pursued them. She stood in front of the last of the clones, surrounded by Dread Walkers, reverted

to her human form and, standing naked in front of him, came closer.

“My death doesn't matter. Horde Prime will return and…” He spoke in a religious exultation, but Lady Sorrowflame put a finger to his lips.

“Shhh. Everything will be fine. Soon you will serve a new and better lady…for eternity.” and then she sank her black fangs into his neck… and drank his delicious blood

Aftermath

She blinked at the terrible, indescribable monster and Frosta beaming with satisfaction . Absolutely happy Frosta and terrifying monster who stared at her with curiosity in countless eyes.

“Your new friend?” she said completely confused, completely not understanding what she was seeing. Where did Frosta get this monster from, how did she find them, why aren't they chewed?

“Yes, he's my new friend, I don't know his name, but I call him Shogi . It's very nice, if a bit snoty. We found him in the ruins of the First Ones and freed him. Now we're buddies.” Frosta explained cheerfully.

"Yeah," she replied when she realized she was staring at them with her eyes wide open.

However, Kyle smiled and waved vigorously at the monster.

“Hi Shogi , I'm Kyle . Nice to meet you.” said the blond-haired boy in a cheerful voice. She looked at her old friend from the Fright Zone. Kyle was never the bravest of the cadets, but there was no denying his caution and self-preservation. It was almost like the litmus paper they used in the old days to test for hydrochloric acid in the sink water . If he wasn't afraid of something, that meant it wasn't really dangerous. Melog didn't seem scared either, just a bit confused. So she decided to trust her friend's judgment and, relaxing, smiled at Shogoth Shogi and said try to sound as friendly as possible.

“Hello Shogi . I am Catra and this is my companion Melog.” She pointed to the translucent cat. "I guess you saved us from being pierced like a sieve, for which I thank you."

“Blurp!” Shogoth greeted and brushed her hand with a tentacle, showing a surprising delicacy. There was smell of wet mud around

him, definitely not the worst smell she had ever known.

“Did you find him here? So is there anyone else here?” Kyle asked hopefully.

Frosta nodded vigorously.

“Yes, your friend is here. She... has something important to tell you.” said the Ice Princess in an excited voice. Then a figure wrapped in fur emerged from the shadows.

“Hello, Kyle . I'm glad Lonnie decided to save me, and I'm glad you took part in it.” she said in a voice that took a moment to recognize as Scarlet's. She tensed up a bit , but the sorcerer didn't seem to have any hostile intentions towards them.

“Oh, how wonderfully glad I am to see you and that you are safe and sound!” Kyle exclaimed with undisguised joy. She thought she saw sadness and disappointment in Frosta's eyes , but before she could ask how they got here, she saw a rainbow flash.

She was immersed in the light, she felt that she was swimming in a river of bright. She knew there was a cold dead void beyond its shores, and if she allowed herself to be swept out by the incredibly fast current, she would be forever trapped in darkness. She had to be strong... She had to be brave... She had to fight with all her strength... For her... For Catra. "Evil is coming. There are shadows all around.” she heard the voices in her head, imperious and insistent. However, she did not pay attention to them, she had to save Catra. Her beloved. Her dearest... There were monsters born of darkness in the void, waiting only to devour anyone who emerged from the river. She also felt the presence of other beings. They weren't hostile to her, but they wanted something from her, something very important. They foretold something to her, a future that was destined for her. It terrified her…they terrified her, but she couldn't afford to be afraid, all would be lost… So, despite the horror that gripped her heart,

she plodded on. *If I stop... If I look back, I'm lost* she thought half-consciously, swimming with a current of light that burned her like fire and was cold like the dark emptiness of space at the same time. She was already reaching the end of this journey, she felt that the exit was at hand. "A shining road. A road meant for you. The Loneliest Road. The road you must follow" she heard inside her soul as she reached the end of her journey. Then she was in the dark...

She took a deep breath, feeling as if she had come out of the depths of the sea. She was in a large cave plunged into darkness. However, her inner glow dispelled the darkness, allowing her to see a terrifying scene. She saw Catra, her beloved, alive and well, though her shirt was dirty and stained with slime, staring at her in understandable surprise. But there was a terrible monster nearby. It was huge and shapeless, with hundreds of eyes and mouths and tentacles, one of which was just reaching towards Catra!

"Leave her alone, you… monster." she called in a loud voice, although she herself was not quite sure what to call this terrible creature and slashed its tentacle. The creature let out a loud gurgling sound and began to back away, and she continued to attack… Until her legs were trapped in ice.

"Adora, don't hurt Shogi ! He's our friend." she heard Frosta shouting at her in a desperate voice. She turned to see the Ice Princess looking at her pleadingly. Beside her, she saw Kyle sheathing some strange sword. Her old friend was wearing some kind of uniform, now an obscenely dirty… She remembered that Lonnie had created this People's Rebellion of hers. Next to him, she saw a red-haired woman dressed in furs, whom she recognized after a moment as Scarlet, her old friend from the Horror Zone, whom she hardly remembered. She felt the touch of a well-known hand on her shoulder and turned to look at Catra's gently smiling face.

“Everything's all right. This creature is friendly despite its… unusual appearance. He saved us, me and Kyle when the First Ones robots were chasing us… They really hate cats.” She laughed amiably. She looked at the monster, which cowered in fear. He looked at her apologetically, the way a pet would look at someone it made angry, though it didn't know what it had done wrong. She felt ashamed of how she had treated them. She lowered her sword and turned to... Shogi .

“I am very sorry that I attacked you, but it was a terrible day and recently I heard that someone was threatening my girlfriend, and when I saw you I thought you wanted to hurt her and ...” She looked at the creature, which clearly "relaxed". In fact , he began to look at them with interest, as if he recognized her.

“Yes, I am her. I'm She-Ra. How do you know me?” she asked, she herself wasn't sure who, while Frosta removed the ice around her legs and said.

“Yes, Shogi know you. Another She-Ra, fought such Old Things long ago and set Shogis free!” There was genuine delight in the Ice Princess's voice.

“We're actually talking about the Elder Things and the Shogots. two ancient races much older than the First Ones.” Scarlet corrected Frosta . Oddly, she sounded a bit like a Shadow Weaver when anyone around her was wrong, though of course she didn't threaten to electrocute anyone. Butwhen her friend got into this habit... Although, on the other hand, they hadn't seen each other for five years, and even before that they hadn't been particularly close. Recalling the dark sorceress, she involuntarily shuddered… she remembered the shadow that seemed to be watching her in Clytemnestra. Surely it's just an illusion created by fighting a warship.

“Uh, Elders Things? Former She-Ra?” she asked confused, also trying to pull herself out of unpleasant thoughts.

“It's a long and rather gloomy story ...” said her fiancée in a serious voice, but then smiled cheekily and asked. "You'd better tell me since I've become such a damsel in distress that her beloved must come to save her from another planet. Actually, how did you do it?” she asked.

“I did something similar when I defeated Horde Prime, but this time it was much more difficult.” she thought, remembering her recent journey through the river of light. She wasn't sure how much of what she experienced then was real, but she had an overwhelming sense of terrible destiny while in that place... "But I had to risk it because I had a dream and then..." She looked at the others, it wasn't time to tell them yet about Angela and what happened to her. “It's also a long and grim story.”

She saw Catra frown when she mentioned the dream, but then she smiled and said.

“It was hard, but Frosta came with her new friends to help and they destroyed these creatures.” She pointed to the shattered body of some metal insect somewhat resembling a mosquito, only the size of a cow. “She's our heroine." she gave the girl a buddy's shake, and Frost jumped with joy, but when she landed, she winced in pain.

“Are you OK?” they asked simultaneously.

“I was bitten by a saber-toothed penguin , but Shogi bandaged me.” She rolled up her trouser leg, showing an elastic bandage made of a substance similar to that Shogoth was made of . "But I wouldn't have survived if it wasn't for my new friend." She pointed to Scarlet, who nodded politely and said.

“We were trapped together, so helping each other was just a matter of common sense.” the former cadet explained.

She smiled at Frosta and walked over to her, then drew her sword.

"The Shogi did well, but as long as I'm She- Ra , I'll use my power and heal you” She said and flooded her friend's leg with healing

power. To her surprise, she didn't have to use much of it, apparently Shogi's bandage had worked.

Frosta moved her leg a few times and smiled happily. Then she closed her eyes and with great effort sent back the power. It was then that she felt the exhaustion flooding her previously filled with power body. She staggered, but Catra immediately came to her to steady her.

“Are you okay too?” her fiancée asked.

She smiled weakly at Catry.

“I just teleported from another planet... and before that I was fighting a pirate ship... it was a really long and exhausting day.” She said laying her head on her girlfriend's shoulder.

"I see," Catra said and kissed her tenderly and began to purr loudly as Melog started rubbing against her legs.

Frosta rolled her eyes, Kyle blushed, and Scarlet cleared her throat meaningfully and said.

“We still have a long way to go, especially for me and Kyle, and I prefer that Lonnie doesn't meet us here by chance, because then it will end very badly for many of us.”

She looked questioningly at Catra , who sighed.

“Lonnie and I had a little quarrel here earlier.”

She raised an eyebrow.

“Like Hordak and you ?” she asked with slight amusement, but Catra replied with a sour smile.

"Almost… Scarlet's right, the sooner we leave this place the better for all of us." she said with a hint of sadness in her voice.

“Where could they be! It's been over two hours!” she growled. She'd been in the damn cave all day, trapped and powerless. During all those years of war, she hadn't felt as powerless as she did now... Maybe she'd overdone it. When chipped Spinny was much worse, then she thought she had lost her wife forever and there was nothing she could do about it... But now she was completely useless. She felt like she was more of a hindrance than a help because of her broken arm. Lance and George were already more useful, and they were just bloody librarians! So she walked back and forth cursing what Etheria was standing on. She wondered if she had already made her way through the cave floor. “You know, this complex is huge. It probably stretches all the way through the mountain range.” Lance said looking at the stalagmite.

“Underneath all of Etheria, actually .” Entrapta interjected. She was building some device whose purpose only she knew.

“How is it all Etheria?” she asked the inventor with a little fright.

“You know, our planet is not like others. We have no sun, only magical moons, and the interior is a larger maze of tunnels and caves than Dryll. Maybe someday I'll build a special vehicle and we'll organize an expedition to the center of Etheria! We will go there together, there will also be Adora, Glimmer and of course Hordak.” Entrapta said in an increasingly dreamy voice. She sighed heavily. Perhaps she should explain to her friend that locking Hordak, Catra and Glimmer in one place could end tragically, not to mention the odds of Hordak being allowed to leave Beast Island, but she thought it would be cruel ... Or maybe that's what a true friend should do ... However, she failed to finish her thoughts, because the stones in the heap trembled and one of them was pulled inside creating a passage, and Frost stood in it, who happily waved to them.

"Hi, how are you”" she called as if she had come back from an afternoon stroll

They looked at her speechless with surprise and relief, but their amazement increased incomparably when Catra, Melog and… Adora stood behind the Ice Princess. She had no idea where she came from. She was supposed to be on Icarus, or whatever that planet was called?

"You didn't expect me, but she had to come here because I felt that something was threatening Catra, but when I arrived here, it turned out that the girls are doing great without me, with the help of their new friends." They moved away and made room for others. The redhead sorceress stood in the passageway and a skinny blonde. At the sight of them, she tensed, instinctively preparing for a fight, until her broken arm ached, but when she saw a tentacle with many eyes staring at them timidly, she wanted to summon an energy net, but then Catra was at her side in two leaps

"Relax. Now it's friends who helped us survive in those caves. This monster is Shogi Shogoth . He's much nicer than he looks."

She blinked a few times, looking from the creature to Catra and back again, and asked slowly.

"You have a fascinating story to tell."

"you don't even know how much weird" said the feline woman.

Everyone, including this strange creature, went downstairs, and then Catra and Frosta, with a little help from Scarlet and Kyle, what were the names of the People's Rebellion members, explained briefly what had happened.

"How did you came here? That's hundreds of light years away!" Entrapta asked, examining Adora with some sort of radiation sensor. "No, it doesn't look like you're going to die anytime soon or grow a second head. The latter would be really fascinating, don't you think?"

Adora was probably so exhausted that she didn't even pay much attention to the words of the purple-haired woman and said in a tired voice.

"Yeah, that would be interesting," she yawned, "I have no idea how it happened, I just felt like I could do it. You know, magi did it and so on."

Then, with the help of this strange, if indeed kind, creature, they were able to clear a path outside. It was light, it was just dawn, so they had to stay in the dark all night. Terrible. Now she felt an overwhelming exhaustion creep over her. The Pain in her makeshift bandage hand was unbearable, but then Frosta offered to let her new friend bandage her hand. With rather serious hesitation, she allowed him to do so, and indeed, thanks to the strange bandage, the pain eased. It was then that they had to separate. Catra walked over to Frosty and addressed her seriously,

"You know, it's going to be a bit difficult for us to fit Shogi in Silverwing"

Shogoth heard her and suddenly he started bending and squeezing and turned into a chest with legs...

"Oh, and you could turn into a Goat!?" Frost exclaimed delightedly.

Shogi began to transform again and turned into a goat. The size of a cow and with a single eye on his forehead, but actually he looked just like a normal goat.

"You're so cute!" she called, and Shogi chirped…he needs some work on that.

Then Kyle walked over to Lance and George, sword in hand.

"I guess it belongs to you. It's a really great sword, it saved me and Catra's life It's really very sharp." He stretched out his hands, handing them the sword.

The two men looked at each other and smiled at each other, then handed Kyle the blade and Lance spoke.

“Take it, it will serve you better-“

"Neither of our sons are interested in fencing anyway," added George.

Kyle turned red and tears flowed from his eyes.

- It's so nice. No one has ever given me anything so precious. At least one thing we will take away from this trip.”

"And why exactly did you come here?" she asked.

The boy sighed and started talking.

"Because we came here for the transponder, but the broadcast tower was destroyed and we found out about this city so Lonnie thought there might be some kind of weapon in here, she just saw Catra and she kind of lost her temper, and I'm so sorry about that." Kyle exuded sadness , and even Scarlet seemed embarrassed.

“Transponder! It can be done!” Entrapta exclaimed cheerfully and began to search Alice. After a while, she took something strange out of it. "Please take it, I have more than I need anyway." Said the former Lady of Dryl. She wasn't sure if it was a wise idea, after all, Lonnie recently wanted to kill them, but seeing the joy in Kyle's eyes, she decided to give peace a chance.

He and Scarlet walked along the ridge. It was cold and he was exhausted, but he did something to make Lonnie happy. Though he wasn't sure if it was a good deed. Their girlfriend has been focusing more and more on her… No, their Rebellion lately, and she doesn't care about anything except her fight. He was afraid it would end badly for all of them. Her new allies… They were terrifying, and now, thanks to this transponder or whatever that

thing was, there would be even more of them. No, he didn't like it at all. He looked at Scarlet, who was walking briskly ahead of him. Even though she'd been lost in those stinking caves for much longer than he had, she still didn't look tired. Even Adora seemed more exhausted, while the sorcerer was bursting with energy. How is she k

"You're thinking about throwing that contraption to the heck." said Scarlet with a Sour smile on her face.

“How do you know that ... “he asked scared, but his companion waved her hand.

“Because I considered it myself, but I decided it was pointless. Mi-Go, if they wanted to, could build such a transponder themselves... If they didn't already... No, they wanted to see if the Comrade General was up to the task they assigned to her... This time Lonnie didn't provide them with what they really needed. They desired.” explained the sorceress.

“And what did they want from her?” he asked, but his companion didn't answer.

They came to a small depression in the rock, and Scarlet told them to stop.

“Listen Kyle ... Now I'm going to do something I was very afraid of. You will know my biggest secret, so please keep an open mind.” she said and started undressing. It turned out that under the fur coat she had only underwear ... which she also began to get rid of. He started screaming all red.

“Wait! I know you and Lonnie sleep together, and I don't mind. It's not like you have to sleep with me now. Anyway, I'm tired and it's cold!”

However, then Scarlet's body buckled and began to change. She became a tall, tall creature with emerald eyes, pale skin patterned like broken porcelain, and hands ending in sharp claws. He drew his sword and pointed it at the creature.

- Stay away. What have you done with Scarlet! he shouted. For a moment, he thought some horrible creature had eaten Scarlet and taken her form, but then he understood what the creature was, and then he felt real fear.

" Kyle, it's still me..." the creature said to him in a soft voice, and there was pain in her eyes, but he was too scared to think about it.

“I… I can fight. I have the power ...” he said and suddenly the light around him flashed. Power surged through him. He began to transform. He grew taller and stronger, his cape billowing behind his back, and his hair grew even more. He knew what had happened to him, though he had no idea why.

“No no no!” he shouted in a deep, unfamiliar voice.

“Kyle?” asked the being who had been Scarlet not long ago, staring at him in disbelief, as amazed as he was.

“Yes, it's me Kyle ... I want to be Kyle again. Only Kyle!” he shouted and dropped his sword, then returned to his former self. Scarlet, or the creature claiming to be her, picked up the weapon and studied it with interest.

“Weird, as far as I know, there should be some Writings here.” she said in a thoughtful voice

“They are, can't you see them? There it writes that it is called a sword of power and so on.” he explained, still bordering on panic.

“And what do these inscriptions look like?” the creature asked cautiously.

"Yeah, like someone's connected the stars, but I can read them normally." he explained, and then the creature looked at him, as he had looked at her before. As if he was a completely alien and dangerous being. You was a terrible feeling.

“Well, yes, you are Adora's age, in fact you are quite similar, you have the same type of beauty. You're just so mediocre that no one noticed.” said the being in a voice so different from that of his old friend. He was terrified of the truth hidden in the words of his… companion? It was all too scary to think about!

“Shadow Weaver, of course, suspected nothing. I wonder what else she didn't see in her arrogance? I need to talk to Dr. Moors, considering what he said to Catra, he must know a lot of secrets that the cadets keep, but I'm thinking we'll talk to Lonnie first, I'm sure she'll be thrilled to know your secret, don't you think?” The creature smiled, showing sharp teeth.

Overwhelmed by indescribable Terror, he shook his head vigorously and spoke imploringly.

“Please... don't do this. When Adora found that sword and infuriated Catra about it, you don't know what was going on... Or you do. If Lonnie finds out, she won't forgive me, and Rogelio will probably get hit right away . I love them both. Please, I don't want to lose them.

The person he had known before as Scarlet came up to him and, kneeling down beside him, said.

“All right, let's make a deal now. First, you won't tell Lonna who I am, and two, you'll let me know the secrets of this sword and yours. I'll keep your secret to myself in return, what's your deal? Not that you have a choice.”

He nodded his head, tears streaming down his face.

It was dusk when they stopped and lit a fire. Even Frosta, despite all her inexhaustible energy, was dozing off, almost scorching the marshmallows Kyle had given her . Netossa pretended not to be asleep at all, although her head dropped every now and then. Her hand was much better now. Lance and George just went to sleep

and snored so loud you could probably hear them for miles around. Melog and Shogi played like little pets until they fell asleep. Many forgot that her companion was not a cat at all, but a creature as amorphous and shapeshifting as Frosta's new friend . He was left alone now and she laid her head on Adora's shoulder. She massaged her thigh and he purred loudly. She kissed her neck. She could smell the captivating scent of her fiancée. She felt such overwhelming desire that she wanted to drag her to the tent and make passionate love to her all night and then all morning ... But first she had to do something ... Yes, now she will tell her. He will reveal the truth about her origins. She looked into the eyes of her beloved and then she understood that something had happened. Adora stared at the fire, deep in thought. She became withdrawn again, as she often did when she was in trouble. Something very bad must have happened there on Icarus.

“Adora, you know, you can tell me anything.” she asked Adora, who took a deep breath and began to tell her in a broken voice.

“I wanted Glimmer to be the first to know about it, because it concerns her the most, but i need to tell someone about it. When I was on Icarus , I had a very bad dream first, and then I was warned about the Slave of Ice and… Shadow of the Moon. I murdered the Clock after that and this one Ivory Claw accused me and I had to spend some time alone... Then I met some nice kids and we went to the capital and there was Lady Cala Grayskull and... Never mind because after that Angela... Queen Angela lives.

Her heart stopped for a moment, then tears of joy filled her eyes. Queen Angela, mother Glimmer is alive. Her greatest sin was opening the portal, and if it wasn't for the queen's sacrifice, everyone would be lost... It always weighed on her conscience, but if she lived, it was wonderful...

“Oh, that's amazing. Tell!” she shouted happily, but Adora was not happy, she seemed to be terrified, even broken...

“She tried to kill us, she wanted to burn the city down, and she murdered an innocent child. She is a monster. she became a monster because of me.

On the way back, she told Kyle the same story she had told Frosta, albeit in a more dry form. At last they reached the entrance to the side tunnels. They had notified Lonnie via Comms earlier, so Rogelio was waiting for them and greeted Kyle affectionately, then led them both to Lonnie. Comrade General did not look very well. The wound on her face looked nasty, and she wasn't sure even her magic would be enough to heal it. But when she saw them, Lonnie smiled with relief. Seeing this, she felt bitterness in her heart. She knew all too well how Comrade General would react to seeing her true self. Good-natured Kyle drew his sword at the sight of her, and what Lonnie, who was already suspicious and full of anger, would do was predictable. For a moment, she seriously considered Frosta's proposal, there was really little to keep her in the People's Rebellion, so she would have nothing to regret. She also suspected that knowing the princesses would protect her from the revenge of the cults. But then what? Following a straight and clear path, she would not gain the power she wanted ... which she needed. And, of course, there was the promise that was made to her... She's ready to do almost anything for Scarlet.

They told Lonnie the story they had established between themselves. Kyle didn't even have to lie, which was good because he was a tragic liar. She just missed a few details. There was only one problem she had to solve. At first she considered justifying her lack of clothes by saying that she and Ice Princess had spent some time "getting to know each other" but then they had to run away, but she thought it sounded silly and might be mean to her new... friend, she just said she had to change shape, a good lie should be as close to the truth as possible after all. Lonnie didn't go into detail anyway, maybe the wound was bothering her too much, or maybe she was thinking about something else. Comrade General, as soon as she found out about She- Ra's return and

Frosty's new pet, clenched her fists angrily, but said nothing. Then Kyle showed her the transponder she had obtained , and she showed the crystal that Frost had inadvertently given her.

"They say Entrapta was able to extract data from it, so maybe we can."

Lonnie tossed the crystal in her hand and said in an oddly thoughtful voice.

“Entrapta has a truly exceptional mind” and told them to follow her. They walked for a quarter of an hour through a narrow tunnel leading to a ledge.

“We came across this when we were looking for you.” she said and pointed to the glacier stretching out in front of them. Only after a moment did she understand what was there. It was a ship, a gigantic, mile-long First Ones warship, only a tiny fragment of which protruded from the ice.

“How many lives is worth such a ship? asked Lonnie with barely concealed despair.

Conclusions

Conclusions

He barely managed to avoid a bump on his head as they raced to the ship as if an enemy were chasing them. He tried discreetly to ask Bina to turn back, because he had something important to say, preferably to show Adora, but the captain paid him no attention. She was terrified, though he didn't quite understand why. After all, what happened wasn't their fault. Whatever Captain Moonshadow did…Queen Angela…Captain Queen Angela Moonshadow did, there was definitely an explanation for that… It must have been a mistake. Some terrible but explainable mistake. Only if Lady Cala not hadn’t said it was true... She wouldn't lie to them, and she couldn't be wrong.

He wished he had said everything when he had the chance. He was just waiting for the right, perfect moment, and it turned out that he had waited too long... But that wasn't the only thing. Eti was very... Specific... Secretive and distrustful. For a brief moment he managed to get close to her, and then she discovered his secret, and he became Wormdak again... He wanted her to show them who she was, and then... He just realized that he had no idea what would happen then. He thought that Adora would be happy if she knew Eti's identity, after all, she already liked her... But he had no idea who this girl was. She was like him, artificially created, just like Bina... But why would this Jantar create someone like Catra? And how, if he counted correctly, although measuring time was never his strong point, Eti was created about six years ago... That is, when Etheria was still hidden. He had absolutely no idea how to understand it.

“We're here, and we haven't even run over anyone”. the captain called when they arrived and she laughed nervously.

“It's a disgraceful failure.” grumbled Crushey in an offended voice. They were greeted by a drone guided by Mr. Ilemshaw.

They began to hurriedly unload onto the ship, and the transporter came aboard, but then Eti gave a loud cry.

“Oh no, we have to go back. We left a packet of onion crisps there!”

“What the fuck?” Bina yelled furiously at her ward.

“Excuse me, but you always warn us against wasting food. Lilka wanted to give them to Vegie , because she is vegan and didn't want to eat bacon crisps, but she didn't want to eat them either and we lost them, by the way.” Eti said, but Bina didn't let her finish and screamed at her.

‘STOP PISS ME OF.” and then she took a deep breath and continued in a calmer voice. "You've done enough already. First of all, you bunch of lunatics, you've got yourself caught up in a battle between a deranged pirate captain and... who knows who this She-Ra girl is.”

The feline girl tilted her head and replied the captain with complete calmness in that strange, aristocratic accent she got when she was a bit… flustered….

“Excuse me, but I must point out that the course of events was completely different. It was we, during a completely routine and security patrol, who made friends with this She- Ra and the two princesses, which would greatly help us in our mission, and it was you, my dear Bina, who yelled at them, exposing us to their unbridled revenge.”

Bina looked at her coldly and spoke, her voice both calm and hard.

“Never address me as "my dear", and secondly, Eterna , go to your cabin and wait there until you calm down. The rest is to prepare the ship for departure.”

"And where are we actually going..." Arkan-tar asked. "Because now it's not so obvious." he explained, smiling slyly.

Bina thought for a moment before answering.

“To Etheria, exactly as planned. This is probably the safest place for us right now.” She looked after Eti entering the ship, behind who Toshi flew. “She's right, we have high-ranking friends there now. Maybe I was a bit too harsh on her. And you, my dear, are you coming inside with me, because we have a lot to talk about.” she pointed at him.

"I guess I'll go with you too," said Dilayla, and then he had the impression that Rechiza and Arkan-tar gave her meaningful looks.

“Well, as the captain prefers. he said cautiously, feeling a bit guilty.

"Doctor Quin said she has some important information for all of you related to her research.” said Mr. Iemshaw via one of his drones.

"We'll deal with that in orbit, one problem at a time." Bina said, rubbing her forehead with her hands

Dilayla felt… no, not guilty, that was far too mild a word… She felt like a despicable traitor. The one who betrayed all the values that guided in life. Her faith...was never very strong, but it was part of her. She was the anchor that kept her from drifting into the sea of cynicism and vice that other mercenaries wallowed in. And now she was crossing its fetid waters alone, and she definitely wasn't feeling good about it. She had betrayed the goddess, the Inheritor, or at least someone who was her local incarnation. For a brief moment, she was ready to tell them the truth, to warn them about the Lord Admiral and the darkness he brought with him, but she hesitated, afraid that the others would judge her. That they will see a traitor in her.

Arkan-Tar approached her, and Rechiza stood behind him, piercing her with a glance.

"You're not going to tell our captain the truth, are you?" he whispered to her. None of the crew members were paying attention to them now, so apparently the scholar thought this was the perfect time to talk about important matters.

“I don't know, if I was a better person, I would say.” she snapped back at Verthani, who only smiled indulgently.

“And what would you achieve by doing so? Bina would kick us out here, including our lovely Rosie, and then what? Will we go to Etheria on our own or will we forget about our, I remind you, extremely important and very profitable mission, and then what?” he said in an irritatingly polite tone.

“I don't care about this mission.” She barely kept from screaming.

"And the Lord Admiral cares a lot, better not to make an enemy of him." There was a warning note in the scholar's voice.

"It's better we get punished than those innocent kids." she drawled, clenching her metal fists.

"It's doubtful that someone like Antares would want anything from this pack. He's a great commander, someone who thinks on a global scale. Anyway, all you can do is put them in real danger.”

She frowned and asked.

“What do you mean?

Arkan-tar smiled broadly and said.

"If you warn Bina, she'll do something stupid like want to leave the Zone, she'll only put herself in danger from the Lord Admiral, if there is any, which I sincerely doubt. The captain was right. Etheria is now the safest place in the region. Its inhabitants defeated Horde Prime, compared to which our principal was like a girl with a knife. He'd probably never even think of going to Etheria, he'd be too busy… fighting for peace and freedom.”

Verthani's words sounded reasonable, and so comfortable.

“All right, I'll do as you say. But remember, if the situation changes, I will not be silent. she said in a firm tone, hoping to convince herself

When she saw Calamity kneeling before Carsai the King and trembling with fear, she remembered another but similar scene when she threw Catra at Hordak's feet, hoping that he would use his vacuum machine on the defenseless girl, as he had done on her many times. The similarity of the two events made her uneasy, afraid of returning to her old ways, to her old self. Perhaps the context of the whole scene was slightly different, but everything was similar enough that she felt an uncontrollable nausea of self-loathing. The outcome of these events also turned out to be quite different.

“I'm begging for forgiveness. Oh creeping Chaos, I…” Calamity said , but stopped when Nyarlathotep's avatar ordered her to be silent.

“Don't beg, it's unworthy of either a mortal or a -divine monster like you, our dear Calamity . We don't blame you for what you did, but for your base motives. You were like a little child who wanted to break the window of a person she didn't like or couldn't stop herself from eating candy. And all this at such an early stage of your mission, and yet much more difficult trials await you.”

“It will never happen again.” the aristocrat was saying, but the great Outer God interrupted her.

“Of course it will happen again if you ever get the chance. It is possible to change the nature of a mortal, although sometimes it requires drastic methods, but not a monster like you, our dear Calamity. That's one of the many reasons we assigned you someone like our wise and righteous Shadow Weaver.” Nyarlathotep said. She didn't have to look at her charge to know

that there was pure hatred in those beautiful blue eyes of hers. She didn't care much and knelt before the Creeping Chaos.

"Thank you for appreciating my contemptible self. However, although in your infinite kindness you have bestowed upon me many favors, I would like to ask you for one more favour." she lowered her eyes, and a smile appeared on the face of the ancient being.

"Ask about anthing, our clemency is limitless, as is the severity of the punishments we impose."

She took a deep breath and said the words she had been preparing for some time.

"Recently I learned the true nature of Lord Admiral Antares, of which in your immeasurable wisdom you are probably aware. We can use it for our Cause. There are still a few people on Etheria who will listen to me, and whose love for their loved ones and common sense may outweigh their hatred of me. Please allow me to pursue my own plan as long as it does not interfere with your other plots."

The Great Outer God tilted his head to the side as if he were amused.

- We will agree to your idea out of pure curiosity. Know that we always plot many schemes. Many plans are guided not only by foresight, but also by love for the infinite ingenuity of mortals and their determination. I'll give you one more gift... There's a conversation going on in the cockpit right now that will warm your heart. And you Calamity remember, our patience has limits. " As they said this, the Nyarlathotep melted away as if they had never been here. She cast another spell, leaning over the obsidian countertop, and Calamity stood beside her curiously.

When they boarded the ship, Ireanis was sleeping in her hammock, snoring so loud she seemed to be sawing a tree, and Miss Daisy took Lady Cala to her room, to which Itel replied with a crooked smile. She and Bina went to the cockpit, where she closed the door and spoke sharply to him.

"When were you going to tell us you were from Etheria?"

He frowned.

“But I'm not from Etheri!” he said. Meanwhile, Dilayla leaned back against the wall, crossing her arms over her chest.

“Don't piss me off anymore. I'm tired of Eti nitpick the words.” Bina growled at him.

He sighed and said looking at his feet.

"When your friends freed me, I didn't know you were going to Etheria, and then when I found out, I thought he'd wait until you knew the truth for yourself. My brother asked me not to tell anyone about Etheria, She- Ra and her secrets. This planet has suffered a lot and my brother was very worried that some other dark forces might want to get the power that is there... I... I thought it wouldn't change anything, you'd see for yourself how wonderful this place is... " he explained and smiled at the Captain, but she gritted her teeth in annoyance.

"It wouldn't change anything you say… Except we wouldn't worry about flying into the damn heart of the Abyss, where the Lady of Chaos rules and a fate worse than death awaits. You know, I'm immune to propaganda crap, but itel and the rest of my kids were terrified, okay, Eti isn't afraid of anything and not because she's brave. You cannot imagine how many fears, worries and sorrows you caused us with your silence.”

Now he looked sad. He understood that others might not understand what a good place Etheria was. The lies, hideous and vile, that the Horde Ultimate spread might not have sounded as

false to others as they did to him. He was about to apologize to her, but then Dilayla cut in.

"I knew everything too... I mean, not everything, but that he was on Etheria, and it's not such a bad place at all.” She closed her eyes and continued. “They destroyed Horde Prime, the one who took my family. If they feel they have reason to hide the existence of their planet from the rest of the universe, I will respect that. To be honest, i'm actually going to give them a thumbs up. I've served too many sons of bitches in my life not to believe that every good deed will sooner or later be punished..” She looked sideways, her eyes the same as his brother's when he broods over the past. Bina massaged her forehead between her eyes and said.

“Well, what has been done cannot be undone. Just tell me with your hand on your heart, you didn't know who Captain Moonshadow was.”

He shook his head sadly.

“I had no idea. I've never met her. She left before... Before I was given my freedom. She... She was very loved on her planet... I don't understand why she wanted to kill Adora ...” He felt so down and felt tears come to his eyes. It was all so…. Sad

“Sentient beings change, that's one of the things that distinguishes them from objects. What can change its nature? Sometimes all it takes is just the right amount of despair, suffering and hopelessness.” Bina said in a thoughtful tone.

"Maybe it's something we're not seeing. We don't know what else was done to her... What did the Azlanti did to her... Besides enslavement. Sometimes that alone is enough to break someone and make them a stranger. I've seen it more than once in my mercenary life.” Dilayla added, approached him, and then placed her metal hand on his shoulder, smiling reassuringly. "But there's always a chance to save someone… I believe your friends can handle it. But I guess we need to discuss another matter... Who is Catra? Why did you think they are similar to Et? What connects

them?” said the mercenary looking at the two interlocutors. He sighed, frowning, and said.

“I've never been very good at distinguishing faces. We were created in such a way that only one face mattered to us... That's why I was wrong. Eti… She is very similar to Catra, although they are not identical. Catra... I met her at the same time I was liberated... Her friends, Adora, Glimmer, Bow and of course Entrapta came to Velvet Glove to save her... To tear her out of His hands. Horde Prime's Hands .” he swallowed loudly and continued. “Catra and Adora grew up together in the place where my older brother Hordak ruled. He wanted to conquer Etheria in the name of Horde Prime and trained orphans like them to be soldiers. It was very difficult for them, especially Catra. The training was hard and brutal. They were very wronged. There was a sorceress there... She wore a mask because her face was covered with scars. She raised them, conditioned them, but she was very bad to Catra...” From the corner of his eye, he saw Dilayla suddenly turn pale. “When Adora found the sword and became She-Ra ... They separated. Catra fought ruthlessly for power in the Horde until she became my brother's second in command. She waged war, regardless of the cost, until almost everything was lost...” He smiled serenely and looked at the women. “But everything is fine now. Adora and Catra are going to get married! It's so wonderful!

Bina smiled crookedly.

“Yeah, truly wonderful.” she laughed, but it was a laugh completely devoid of joy. “Now you probably want to know what's going on with Eti... Okay, so I'll tell you part of the truth, because you haven't earned the whole truth yet... It's too dangerous both for you and for us. This Catra of yours... She's like an older sister to our Eti. Twenty-five years ago our Father received an assignment. He was supposed to create a human- Pahtra hybrid , a very specific hybrid... With very clearly defined features... He managed to create one child quite quickly, but... it did not meet the demands. Perhaps it was because the child was a baby, or perhaps it was something else... Jantar treated it as a personal

insult. He could have easily made a lot of money by giving such an extraordinary child to a family that would love her, but since our father was a bastard, he sold her cheaply... to some dark and cursed laboratory. There it ended up in the hands of bloody Dr. Sidonius . The same one who built that observatory... He was supposed to send some extremely valuable cargo to a planet hidden in another dimension ... that is, your Etheria... I don't know what the cargo was supposed to be, but it was obviously more valuable than the baby, because he sent it to test it. device... But there was a terrible accident and Sidonius' Elven wife died. It was this Old Leech who copied the Jantar's serum, and that's how we learned the truth about Eti's sister. No one except Sidonius believed that the child had survived the experiment, but from what you said, this girl did..." Then Bina laughed in such a bitter and sad way that he felt her pain. "Only for some damn monster to make her suffer the same fate! Do you understand how fucking unfair this is? Eti had no childhood, just the way she was created, the amount of terrible knowledge that was poured into her mind and the cruel training that she was subjected to... Just so that she could finally live up to our Father expectations, satisfy his perfectionist ego. " She wiped tears from her eyes. "You know, I hoped in my heart that girl survived, that she was found by a nice, loving family, that she grew up to be a joyful and happy young woman who didn't experience what we did, but... But there is no escape from destiny. Our fate is determined by the blood in our veins... your story only confirms this."

He and Dilayla looked at each other, not quite understanding what the captain meant, but then smiled serenely and said.

"But. This is all in the past. Now they can be together, like sisters…" Bina interrupted him by putting her hand on his shoulder. Instinctively, he tensed, because he wasn't used to being touched yet.

"It's not that simple, because you see... Jantar was much more cunning than your brother. He hedged, each of us, upon seeing another who has been separated from our family, must kill her. This is how we were conditioned by our insane father. We...

overcame it with great effort, but Eti... You know how she is every day, and if Jantar had drilled into her head a stronger conditioning than we had, which is very possible considering how much our father hated his first imperfect creation, then when accidentally stumble upon each other... I'm not sure if this should be allowed."

Then Dilayla spread her arms wide and gesticulating strongly, she said in a raised voice.

"Then why the fuck are you going there? You can go anywhere in the galaxy, there is no need to go there.

Bina shook her head and sighed.

}I often ask myself that. Maybe part of me wants them to meet, maybe I want to find something like a new home for my kids, or maybe I believe a bit in Itel's crazy mission and hope to win the war with the swarm? Don't ask about the latter. I can't tell you about that either, but maybe it's just a pipe dream and we'll never heal Captain Blazebringer . Maybe this will be better for the galaxy..."

She arrived just in time to listen to Bina's story . Her suspicions about the connection between Eti and Catra were true, although it raised further questions. Who was this mysterious client of Jantar and what connected him with Etheria, Catra, all of this So who this Doctor Sidonius was was a mystery, the only certainty was that he was a son of a bitch like few others in the galaxy... Though probably not as much as she was, but did such comparisons make any sense? *Yes, I was a monster who almost ruined her life, destroyed her, broke her, twisted her into my own image. She will always bear the scars I caused her that even She-Ra's power cannot heal, though perhaps love will make her forget the pain I caused her. I could have been good to her, or at least better, it wouldn't have cost me anything. But I was just an angry, power-drunk, moonshine-drunk bitch who in her conceit believed she held the key to power, but then thewalls of the cell closed*

around me. I built the palace of my power on a foundation of sand and salt, on foundation of betrayal andpride... and children's tears. She thought, feeling a burning hatred towards herself. Indeed, Crawling Chaos was right, it warmed her dark, rotten heart. However, she learned one of Nyarlathotep's secrets, another piece of this intricate puzzle fell into place.

"You were the doctor's precious cargo…" she said in a low voice.

“Yes, it was me ...” admitted her ward, and for the first time after all the years she spent in her company, she heard pain and sadness in her voice, or something that resembled them very much.

“So that's why you hate it so much.” she asked finally learning another fragment of the dark story that was Calamity .

“I hate her like nothing in the world. – said the blonde woman. “You can't imagine what it's like to know that you came into being and live only to fulfill a destiny that has been taken away from you, making your existence meaningless and pointless.”

She smiled sadly at Lady Cali, feeling a little sympathy for her.

“I abandoned the destiny that was chosen for me.” she confessed to her ward, who smiled at her gently.

“And as a reward, you ended up here with me and we'll have to endure our company for a while...”

Dr. Quin straightened her clothes and looked at the crowd. Rechiza and Arkan-tar were here, the thinking part of their expedition. They were joined by Dilayla and Bina, blue-collar workers who most likely won't be able to get anything from her lecture, but at least they will be able to listen to someone intelligent speaking. There was also Palidus Valgu , the first specimen of his race they had encountered, though she had to admit sadly that while he was quite smart, he had been a huge

disappointment. But now his presence could prove useful. Ilemshaw was also listening to them, who was an interesting creature in itself that would also be worth studying in the future. The aristocrat and the sorceresses weren't here, and neither were the kids who flew this ship. She didn't regret the latter, they would just disturb the adults, but unfortunately they took Rossie with them. She must have gotten used to the lack of any help from the lazy intern.

“So, my dears, we are gathered here to summarize the knowledge we have acquired about the Ravaged Zone, or if you prefer, Horde Prime's Empire.” she cleared her throat and turned on the holographic display. “Horde Prime's Empire was created between two and four thousand years ago, it is difficult to say exactly when, because this region of the galaxy was also affected by the Gap although to a much lesser extent. This in itself bodes well for future research, although history and xenoarchaeology are not my main areas of interest. From the very beginning it was centered around a huge flagship, the latest incarnation of which was known as the Velvet Glove, and the navy surrounding it. This arrangement is extremely important. To an untrained eye, devoid of knowledge in the field of xenobiology and entomology, the initial actions of the Horde resemble the functioning of locusts moving from place to place and devouring all the resources they encounter, but in fact this is only an appearance. The organism that most closely resembles the Horde in nature are some varieties of nomadic ants, although, like any comparison of organisms occurring at different stages of development, this is too much of a simplification. It is significant that the galactic Horde avoided planets devoid of intelligent life or inhabited by civilizations with a low degree of technological advancement. Initially, they were classified as objects of low or negligible threat, but at some point the phrase *To primitive to receive Prime's light* and other similar phrases in this convection began to be used. Horde Prime himself is also quite interesting. Initially, his name appeared only in internal communications. Even then he was treated with humble respect, but then he was not worshiped as a god, like we saw in modern times. In fact, it's a bit like Horde

Prime is hiding among his clones, as if he's too carefull to reveal his true nature. Horde Prime's emergence as the ruler of the known universe coincided with a change in the nature of the empire. Initially, each civilization encountered was conquered and its resources exploited for a short time until the limits of productivity were reached and the entire population that survived the period of occupation was eliminated. But then the pattern changed. An almost normal conquest began to be carried out, somewhat reminiscent of the way the country was managed by the hobgoblins from the lost Golarion, with the total subordination of the entire economy to the military effort, at least at first glance, because in fact, the management of the empire was not only far from rational, but bore all the hallmarks of madness. Sometimes specific tracts of conquered lands were destroyed or spared, it seems only for aesthetic reasons. The occupation was never complete due to limited resources, and sometimes entire areas were left to their own devices, adding to the erratic chaotic nature of the empire. However, every planet, no matter how obedient or strategically important, was left devastated at the end. Plasma and vacuum bombs were used for this purpose, but not nuclear warheads, as if to leave them for future colonization, which never occurred. In general, Horde Prime's actions bear the hallmarks of internal compulsion, as if he was con...” she said, but Arkan-Tar interrupted her.

“An compulsion that has cost the lives of billions... tens or hundreds of billions of lives. Well, what for some is sadistic madness, for others an interesting eccentricity. But how does that relate to the fact that he had three on one side of his face?” the scientist asked and she rubbed her cybernetic eye. Meanwhile, Bina and Dilayla sat deep in thought, probably not following her intelligent argument, and Rechiza smiled sarcastically, probably to hide her intellectual shortcomings. Only Horde Prime's clone took note of everything she said.

“Well, it seems that each of his subsequent incarnations, because from what I understand he has died many times over all these millennia, has been more and more degenerate, like a program

accumulating more and more bugs and glitches. This is apparently a feature quite typical of all extremally long-lived beings.”

Rechiza let out a short, wry laugh.

“It would be best for all of us if you were wrong.”

The witchwarper clearly did not meet the intellectual challenge of her lecture.

Rosie, learning from her recent mistake, knocked on the door before entering Eti's cabin. She and Itel decided to visit the cat girl, after all, Bina had not forbidden it. They heard the rustle of sheets and Eti called from inside.

“You can come in if you want.”

They did as she asked and the intern was glad she knocked because the cat girl greeted them wrapped only in a blanket. Her golden eyes with blue flecks gleamed from under the covers, just like Toshi's grey-blue eyes

“Hello, Eti. Itel and I came here to see how you are feeling and everything.? she said, smiling happily. Itel smiled too, although she looked distressed.

“Because Bina treated you too harshly. After all, this whole expedition was my idea... The one on Icarus too, she should be mad at me.” ad the solarian

The cat girl shrugged.

"I feel... I'm not sure how I feel..." she said and Itel seemed concerned by her words. “I'm not mad at Bina . Sometimes I can be... tiring. I was just hoping that I would come up with some excuse and we would go back to the princesses, so I was talking about whatever was on my mind, hoping that I would come up with something sensible, but you know how I am, once I start

talking, I can't stop. I just hoped that the Blondie... Adora would maybe come back and tell me what was written on my hand, because she is one of the Starlings, that is, the First Ones, and she sees the signs on my hand, so I thought she could read them." She explained, looking ahead with sad eyes.

Itel thought about something for a moment and then said.

"You know, there in the monastery I found out that Rechiza could read... The Language of the First Ones. I didn't tell you because I didn't believe her, but you can ask Lilka or Miss Daisy if it was true."

Then Eti burst out laughing. She didn't hear what it sounded like, but judging by Itel's reaction, it must have been a very unpleasant laugh.

"It's good that you say that, because when that She-Ra vanished, something very funny happened to my hand. "said the cat girl and stretched her hand sharply in front of her. Rosie jumped back in fear and then she and Itel looked at the feline's arm. The elf immediately hissed in fear, but it took her a good while to understand what had changed. Eti's metal arm had grown and now reached past her elbow.

- It's nothing to worry about. It's happened twice before... The problem will be if it reaches the heart or the brain... or maybe not?" Eti wondered

"Don't say such things! Eti, please!" She screamed in true horror this time. The feline girl hid her hand under the covers and looked at them.

"But I don't want to die, if that's what you're worried about. I'm just... different." she said and for the first time she saw sadness on her face. "You see, my soul… my heart is torn in two. When I'm balanced, I don't feel much. I take medications to maintain this condition... But sometimes even they don't help, and then... Then rainy or stormy days come. When there are rainy days, I see

the world as it is... I see how dark and sad a place it is. That there is no good and no hope, that everything tends to darkness. You don't see it because you look away, close your eyes, cover your ears, hoping that the monster will go away. But I can't look away, I look into his eyes. I lie in my cabin all day long, surrounded by the dark truth... But it gets worse, at least for others, when the stormy days come. Then… oh then I am strong. I see the beauty of the world and the pathetic weakness of my enemies. I understand that I am absolutely perfect, awesome and unique. Then I am unstoppable, invincible and I am ready for any madness, any meanness to achieve my goal. Because I know that I am the storm that is raging in my heart... The cold fire that burns inside me" a single tear rolled down her face. "You know, Rosie, there was once another person like me. Only… She was created a child. She could develop normally and explore the world on her own. She didn't have what I had crammed into her head. What it is like to hurt and kill is not shown. For many years I believed she was dead, which made me sad and happy at the same time. But now I know she's alive, don't ask me how, I just know. You see, sometimes I hate her so much. For being able to be whoever she wanted. That he doesn't have the same taint as me. That she can be happy..."

Conspiracies

The wound on Lonnie's face has become infected, making Comrade General delirious and staggered. She kept babbling about the warship they had found hidden in the glacier. She had to admit that the ship was stunning, but for now it was only an archaeological curiosity, completely meaningless. Even if they miraculously managed to get it out from under the ice, they didn't have enough people in the entire People's Rebellion to assemble a crew, not to mention the fact that no one would probably know how to fly it. The other problem was that they had no idea what they would do with a warship like that. Would they fly it to conquer the stars, or would Lonnie intimidate all of Etheria with the threat of an orbital bombardment. She had no idea, but their commander's new obsession could get them into trouble.

It didn't change the fact that Lonnie's health was getting worse, and neither her magic nor Dr. Moors' skills could help her. The antibiotics were too weak, so the brain in cylinder hat concluded that she was probably infected with some fungus that grew so abundantly in the ruins of the city. She remembered the rodents, so overgrown with lichen that their original bodies could not be seen, or the crab spiders, their shells torn apart by fruiting bodies of fungi, and decided that the risk was too great.. So she spoke to the rest of their group, and they agreed that Lonnie needed to go to Dryll as soon as possible. There she would be given much better medical care than what they were able to give out in the open. The duty of taking care for the Comrade General fell to her as a sorcereress with powerful magic, only it was not so simple. She could not use the commonly used Etherian magic, because she did not have enough power or equipment. So she had to perform the appropriate ritual, but it won't be that easy. Firstly, it will cost them valuable time, which they did not have much in store. Besides, her knowledge, compared to that of the sages of the destroyed Umbracor or Arkancor , or even her ... mother, the cursed sorcerer, was still small. However, she knew a few tricks. At

first, she considered summoning Byakhe , a lizard-horse capable of even interstellar travel, but Lonnie, whose riding skills were close to zero even at full strength, would not be able to hold on to the ancient monster's back, so she had to find another solution. So she decided to summon a Star Chariot, although it was more difficult. So he and Rogelio caught two rabbits and, to Kyle's horror, killed them and drained their blood into a bowl, they needed payment after all. Then she began an incantation that lasted over an hour, and suddenly a white sparkling vehicle, drawn by two mounts, resembling a combination of moths and horses, descended from the blue sky. The charioteer was a tall being in a bright, tattered robe that seemed to consist of many interconnected strips of light. She told her companions not to look under the creature's hood for any reason. She added her own blood to the rabbits' blood and gave it to those ghostly steeds of gulping, then boarded the ship, leaving Kyle , Rogelio Imp and Doctor Moors . The four of them were to return the way they had come. Most likely, they won't be stopped by anyone, and even if they did, the current relationship between the Rebellion and the Princess Alliance was good enough not to worry about it. Under other circumstances, Kyle and Rogelio would have jumped at the opportunity to be together and perhaps even extend the trip, but with recent events and Dr. Moors' presence, is unlikely to be in the right mood. So she got into the chariot and set off. The ride was surprisingly pleasant. They flew high in the sky without feeling any tremors, cold dreaming of momentum. And this comfort made her pay attention. She had heard of travelers who fell asleep during this flight, returning after a thousand or more years. So she held an exhausted Lonnie in her arms, fighting as hard as she could to stay awake.

After two hours, they landed in the courtyard of Castle Crypto , much to the surprise of its defenders. As soon as he got out, the vehicle disappeared in a beam of light. She handed the Comrade General over to the other members of the Rebellion and issued orders on how they should take care of her. She was surprised to discover that no one questioned her competence, as if everyone

took it for granted that in the event of the Comrade General indisposition, she would take over her duties, as if she were becoming the second-in-command. In fact, she should be happy about it… But she felt rather scared, because it unsettlingly reminded her of her cursed heritage.

Nothing had changed in the castle since they had left it maybe two weeks ago, which was a bit… disappointing. In life so much happened to the members of their expedition. Lonnie had found a ship for which she was going to commit a terrible deed, though first she would have to capture the Former Lady of Dryll ... But also to convince the other members of the People's Rebellion to her plan, which would not be so easy, even she wasn't sure if she wanted to support her …Unless Creeping Chaos wills it.

But of course, it was this journey that had the biggest impact on Kyle's life. The clumsiest member, first of the entire Horde, and now of the People's Rebellion, turned out to be hiding a huge secret. She wondered if the boy was deliberately hiding the truth about himself, playing the weakling all his life, but that was probably too complicated. But that meant that the Rebellion had its She- Ra.a … Its He-Ra… The name would still need to be thought of. Anyway, they had their prince of power… Which they couldn't use… at least for now. Not only because of her promise, she couldn't risk Lonnie finding out the truth about her, but also because of the Comrade General current attitude towards all things princesses. So keeping this knowledge to themselves would be beneficial to the Great Outer God's Plans by all means... The mere fact that Kyle's veins most likely had the blood of the First Ones opened up great opportunities for them. And the sword... In the name of Nyarlathotep he will possess all its secrets.

Some changes had taken place in her as well, with which she was not entirely happy. Until now, she had had to hide her true nature from almost everyone except for a few of Creeping Chaos' highest-ranking minions, at least those who live on Etheri. Now two people found out about her true nature. One accepted her... Well, perhaps she was too harsh on Kyle . After all, she reminded him of two people he had feared so much all his life, no wonder

she scared him so much. Well, they had a hook for each other, though the blond boy didn't realize that he could hurt Nightgale a lot more than she could hurt him. Yet somehow, the way Frosta looked at her, that she saw him as more than a monster… than an aberration. It made her believe that there was a future for her other than serving the Great Outer God. But she knew what an illusory hope of happiness could be, and that all too often it ended in suffering. Nightgale had learned this bitter truth all too well... However... one, though she knew it was ridiculous, allowed herself to hope for a happy ending... or at least a moment of happiness...

Even this brief transformation in the depths of the earth allowed her to rest from Scarlet's body, so she didn't have to return to her true form now. Still, she took a hot bath, one of the luxuries former cadets had learned in Castle Crypto . She then issued several orders and began preparing a statement addressed to all members of the Rebel . about what had happened during the trip, but then Grizzlor unceremoniously walked to her room and growled in a harsh voice.

'We have guests." He stared at her with his white eyes. She had heard that in the olden days his kind were called Bugbear, and true to their name they were feared by other species. They were ruthless killers, hunting others like prey. Of course, their Etherian kin was much milder, and the former captain was well-liked among the former cadets.

"Who? she asked, looking at him with superiority. They were quite behind each other. Shadow Weaver had stepped on his toes several times, and now he was projecting his dislike of Hordak's deputy to all sorcerers. It would be funny if he knew her true nature, he would probably spit with anger.

"Some guy from the Snow Kingdom, a woman in a wheelchair, and some strange woman with a veil who talks like a shadow bitch."

She frowned. She had no idea who the man was, but she guessed the identities of the other two. The woman was most likely Halo, a

well-known supporter of the People's Rebel postulates , but the woman with her face covered ... "No, it's not time for her yet. It has to be, someone else… ah yes," she understood and smiled nastily.

"Okay, let them come ..." she said, feeling the flame of triumph in her heart. "But in an hour, I still have work to do... I have to get ready to meet our dear guests."

They stood on the balcony with a view of the Dryl mountains and the storm raging around the castle since time immemorial. This place was away from most of the rooms, only one corridor led here, closed with a thick, armored door. The entire castle had many safeguards against magical and not only magical, spying. She wondered Entrapta she knew much about it. She was a trusting person, she probably didn't fully understand the idea of spying, so all these safeguards must have been the work of her ancestors. It would be worth finding out who they were, but it was a mystery that would be solved in the future, and now she had a much more important task ahead of her. And also much more in line with the skills "inherited" from her mother.

She looked at the three gathered. A man with a goat beard with a proud face. A Saihe woman dressed in black with a veil on her face and dark blue eyes, looking at the others with superiority and Halo, because she could recognize her from old photos, looked as if everyone gathered disgusted her. Nightgale was wearing sorcerer's robes with the symbol of the People's Rebellion , loose and a bit too big. It was very practical considering her plans.

"Welcome to Castle Crypto , the capital of the People's Rebel." she said formally. The man and Halo scowled, not hiding their distaste for the fact that one of the princesses' oldest abodes, the unconquered Castle Crypto, had been taken over by a bunch of Horde kids.

"I am the Chancellor of the Kingdom of Snow, but you are not Lonnie as I believe." the man said with superiority in his voice.

"I didn't know Shadow Weaver allowed any sorcerer to stay in the Fright Zone, I expected she hated competition." Halo said curiously, in a slightly nicer tone than the Chancellor. She smiled confidently on her face.

"Five years is plenty of time to learn sorcery. Under the shadowlady, Glimmer learned the art in just a few months." Saihe in the veil snorted hearing the title given by Shadow Weaver. "I am Scarlet, the People's Rebellion's Supreme Sorceress and Lonnie's second-in-command." Comrade General feels indisposed due to an injury she sustained during a secret mission. She gave me all powers of attorney to represent her. She decided to confront Lonnie with a Fait accompli.

"If you say so…" Saiche said "I am Midnight Mask Black Blade of the royal Yago clan and together with Star Sister Halo and the Chancellor of the Kingdom of Snow, we came here to make you an offer..." she looked at her expectantly. Nightgale answered her with a raised eyebrow.

"Talk. The People's Rebellion is open to your suggestions." she said gently. Her guests looked at each other, wondering which of them should speak. Finally, Halo snorted with contempt and slammed her good hand loudly on the table, placing some small object on it that looked like a crystal device of the First Ones, and the Chancellor looked at her and placed a crystal key next to it.

"Once upon a time, the Ladies of Armoria had access to the Armory. Hello began to speak. It was a place beyond time and space where a lot of weapons and other technological marvels were said to be stored. Such as Netossa's bracelet. The grandmother of the present-day ruler of Armoria gave the device that summoned armory to me, and the key to Frosta's mother. After King Umbragen seized her kingdom on behalf of the Horde, she feared that they might fall into the hands of Hordak and the Shadow Weaver." She smiled predatorily with the efficient half of

her face. "We'd like to give them to you… under certain conditions."

“Which ones? she asked suspiciously.” All three of them did not arouse any sympathy in her.

“First of all, we want you to enforce your demands. Above all, we want power to be handed over to the people of Etheri.” said the Chancellor with exultation.

"And demand that Hordak, Entrapta, and of course Shadowweaver be punished if we find out where he is hiding." added Hello.

“You mean Light Spinner, she won't escape the Disgrace she brought on her family by using the alias.”

She frowned. *Do they know anything about Creepng Chaos's plans?*

"It's obvious, that's why we started our fight, although I'm not sure if the Starsisters aren't princesses by any chance." she asked, trying to sound as indifferent as possible. Halo burst out laughing in response.

'It's our business, we're a bit different from other rulers of Etheria.”

She nodded and looked at Midnight Mask questioningly.

“What do you want from us?

Dark blue flames burned in the eyes of the one who used the name of the Black Blade.

“First, we demand that an apology be made to us for the offense of accepting our sister Light Spinner, and that all those responsible, or their relatives and descendants, be handed over to us for a terrible but by all means just punishment Furthermore, we demand that we be given dominion over Mystacor, for it is

blasphemy that the so-called sorcerers to practice the ancient arts without the necessary spiritual guidance. guidance. In return, we offer all the might of the Isles of Sorrow.” shouted the Assassin. Hearing her words, she froze. This woman asked for a lot. Not only did she want to take control of Mystacor , Etheria's only true sorcery school that had prided itself on its independence for centuries, but she also wanted to impose her values on it, so alien to most Etheria. She didn't know much about the culture of the Isles of Sorrow, but like the Scorpions in the days of old, their Shadow Warriors and Dark Shades were one of the planet's few military forces, and they would be a valuable ally in the cause Lonnie was fighting for... Only if they were willing to sacrifice so much for victory. “It is much less than sacrificing one innocent woman. Or much more, depending on how you look at it.

“Your proposal, the Black Blade, is noteworthy, but unfortunately also highly controversial. I may not be entirely objective because of my profession, but agreeing to your conditions could alienate many people who have been sympathetic to our cause to our cause. We have to think everything through very carefully before we make the right decision. She replied, trying to sound as polite as possible.

“But quickly, we will not agree to be led by the nose.” Midnight Mask barked back . Well, to be fair, Shadow Weaver didn't pick up interpersonal skills from home… She sighed and turned to the Chancellor as she had one more question on her mind.

“This key belonged to Frosta's mother so it belongs to her now. By chance, I recently met the Ice Princess, and I have a feeling she didn't agree to give her property to us.” she said in a voice as cold as the glaciers she had so recently visited. A very nasty smile appeared on the chancellor's face.

"Well, Frosta's consent or lack of it no longer matters to the Kingdom of Snow.

She felt sorry for her young friend.

After the talks, she showed her guests around Castle Crypto , or at least the part of it that they managed to explore. They saw former cadets training and their military resources. The Rebel members gave the guests a disapproving look, while the guests especially Midnight Mask, looked at them with contemptuous superiority. Only Halo gave them a few warm smiles. However, the clone that was pushing Sister Star's cart was not too kind to the half-paralyzed woman. As Grizzlor surprisingly eagerly began showing the Chancellor and Midnight around, Halo paused for a moment.

“Have you met Frosta ? What with her.” asked the woman in the wheelchair. She thought for a long moment before answering.

“She was very happy the last time I saw her. Although she was injured, but Adora healed her with the power of She-Ra.” she said finally, deciding to be as honest as possible.

“So She-Ra is back? How? Halo asked, absolutely amazed.

“It seems that he can teleport between planets. Needless to say, this is a very useful skill.”

Halo waved her hand absently and returned to the subject of the Ice Princess.

“Frosta... We've always taken care of her... You probably think I'm a mean bitch for supporting someone like the chancellor, but understand that Etheria needs changes... That... - she didn't finish because she was interrupted.

I don't think anything, and I don't need to understand anything. That's what she put between you and your conscience. Such is the lot of politics , said Scarlet, and left the woman alone with her mute servant and conscience.

The Chancellor then left them by boarding the Skimmer, and then invited Midnight Mask and Halo to her studio. Then she smiled at them and untied her robes.

“Are you craving orgies? I've always known that foreigners are perverted, but I never thought it was so much.” Saihe growled and drew her weapon, though Halo looked at her curiously.

“I just think that we need to talk honestly and seriously, and for this purpose we need to stand... face to face.” she said and transformed, taking her true form. Both women's faces showed horror and disgust, they were slowly starting to get used to it, although in their case such a reaction was fully justified.

“What are you...” asked the Black Blade, getting ready to attack, but with a smile she turned to the Assassins.

“Oh, auntie, I expected that our first meeting would begin with much warmer words.”

Halo tried to get up from the stroller, almost falling over and pursing her lips angrily, she drawled.

“So the dark whore has her spawn after all.”

She shook her head in amusement.

“Not exactly ... There was advanced technology and things like that, but it's not that important at the moment. I would ask you to show the symbols of the gods that you wear around your neck. Then you will meet the master to whom I have sworn allegiance.”

They looked at it, then at each other and took out an amulet in the form of a pendant. One depicted a skull with coins in its sockets, and the other also a skull, but this time wrapped in chains. They were the symbols of Charon, the Horseman of Death and leader of the Daemons, and Zon-Kuthon, lord of suffering and envy.

"Well, I guess now it's time for you." Black blade growled.

Nightgale grinned widely and snapped her fingers. Then the shadow of the light-eater, one of Nyarlathotep's Avatars, materialized in the pre-prepared circle .

“My master, Great Outer God, Creeping Chaos, Nyarlathotep cares only to save the universe. she said, looking the women straight in the eyes, fully aware that in the future one of them would betray her.

Black clouds are gathering.

Shimah walked through the corridors of Divinis, the new capital of the Prime Empire , or rather the Horde’s Ultimate Empire, his only rightful successor. Her beloved. She was bringing him important news, urgent news.

The city wasn't large, at least by the standards of the Pact Worlds, but it had grown nonetheless since Horde Ultimate's coronation as Emperor of the Known Worlds and heir to Horde Prime, and now housed three hundred thousand inhabitants. The planet it was on was Andromede, a place on the fringe of the empire, inhabited by bald dwarves and some strange variety of Ysoki similar to beavers or moles. Both races did not put up any serious resistance to the Horde, quickly recognizing the superiority of the Empire and becoming part of it. The entire system was full of precious raw materials extracted from the bowels of the planet, but also from nearby planetoids. Before the arrival of the Horde, there was already a totalitarian dictatorship here and the locals were used to heavy-handed rule, and in fact, Prime's rule was, in its own way, an improvement in the situation for the locals, because the insane ruler of the "Known Universe" was not interested in personally supervising each conquered planet. Just before Prime's Horde fell, it was converted to become a launching point for subsequent conquests, so when he died, there were plenty of troops and supplies stationed here, and an industrial base to replenish losses. That's why she decided that this place was perfect for the capital of empire of her beloved.

She passed many clone guards clad in golden armor and armed with heavy blades, whom they called the Firstborns. They were among the best trained warriors of their country and enjoyed many privileges. They received the best food, Great Names and Noble Titles. The palace guards were favorable to her because she was the one who came up with the idea to create their formation. The other clones had much more ambivalent feelings for her.

They took over the palace from the former Grand Magister, a dictator who had ruled the entire system and even several colonies with an iron fist for a hundred years, until the Horde arrived and he was killed by his own supporters after first loses. It was beautiful, full of brass decorations and intricately made bas-reliefs depicting scenes from mythology and ancient stories. Many had to be restored because they depicted scenes that Horde Prime deemed blasphemous and ordered destroyed. He also ordered his images to be placed here. They managed to remove many of them under the pretext that it was not fitting for his divine face to be sullied by the sight of simple, everyday matters, but they had to leave a few of them. The power required costs, including those of an aesthetic nature. Overall, though, she liked the palace, even if, as someone who had grown up among the labyrinthine corridors of the Apostate, the place definitely lacked a bit of its dark, sophisticated charm. But she didn't leave her home and break all ties with him just to miss him in such a distant corner of the galaxy.

Finally, she stood in front of the bronze doors leading to the Throne Room. Chamberlain Grundar, a tall and athletic dwarf and her protégé, addressed her in a formal tone.

"The Great Horde Ultimate is currently receiving a delegation from the moons of Mios."

"I have important news intended only for the ears of the Great Horde Ultimate. – She said imperiously and the dwarf, without asking any further questions, ordered the gates to be opened. He was a really good servant.

Waiting for them inside were several Ysoki wearing as much clothing as the miners could afford. Apart from them, there was also Seneschal Shrik, Ysoki and the third person in their empire, whom they met right after they reached this planet, when he almost single-handedly maintained some semblance of order on this planet when Chaos reigned throughout the empire after the death of Horde Prime. He was an extremely talented, if very neurotic, workaholic and, most importantly, he was absolutely

devoted to them. On this planet, as in many places in the galaxy, the Ysoki were second-class citizens and often had to fight for their position among other races. Here, thanks to Horde Prime, who usually oppressed everyone equally, their situation improved slightly.

Horde Ultimate sat on a bronze throne decorated with rubies, wearing light, bronze-like armor with a beautiful crown shaped like the Horde's symbol. As soon as she entered, he turned to her, because he immediately noticed that something very important had happened.

"Do you bring any important news Shimach , the Voice of the Horde, the one who speaks in His name?" he turned to her with full seriousness.

“I have received news that you should listen to, my lord.” she said, bowing slightly.

Horde Ultimate gestured for everyone to leave, but she said.

“Let Shrik stay, for the news I bring concerns the entire empire.” she said with a bit of religious exultation that perfectly suited the current situation.

Ysoki remained watching them uncertainly and a little scared. Once the three of them were together, her beloved, Horde Ultimate, got up from his throne and walked over to her.

“What happened, tell me!” he ordered. Anxiety appeared on his face, which was marred by countless scars. There were reasons for him, they had known each other long enough for him to recognize when she felt genuine fear. An emerald flame burned in his grieen eyes.

“Taurus has been conquered.” she said and waited for the others to digest her words.

“So did She-Ra finally decide to do something, or did my brothers get brave and decide to strike?”

She shook her head and said.

“It's none of them. It's someone from the outside.” she said and Horde Ultimate turned his back to her and clenched his fists filled with anger. Still, after all these years, after the countless cruelties he had suffered at the hands of his Big Brother, the fact that he had turned out to be a vile liar still hurt him.

“I warned you that it would happen someday, although I hoped we would have a little more time.” she said in an apologetic voice, but he waved his hand to show that he had no grudge against her and asked.

“Who they are?” he asked, taking a deep breath.

“According to my informants, they present themselves as the Research and Exploration Fleet, but let's not be fooled by the name, because they have warships and an army. It took them three days to pacify Taurus and it appears that they did not suffer many losses during the invasion.” she said. Horde Ultimate turned to her and said.

“Do you know who they serve?”

She thought about the answer, because it was actually not easy to give it.

“From what they say in their communicates, they have the support of the greatest powers of the galaxy, I guess it's definitely the Pact Worlds, perhaps the Veskarium. Fleet is commanded by Lord Admiral Antares.

“Who is this person?” Shrik asked with fear in his voice. She frowned and said slowly, trying to remember as much as possible from her old life.

“The Lord Admiral Antares is a mercenary, someone who fights for money, but not just any gun for hire. It has its own war fleet. He fought Swarm, an enemy that makes even your brother seem like a local warlord. We've never met, but I know a little about him

because of my former profession and I've heard a lot about him... He has a good reputation, he's considered a hero, but apparently he hides many dark secrets. He is an extremely dangerous opponent that we should not underestimate."

Ysoki shivered and began nervously nibbling the tip of his tail.

"So… what do we do now?" he asked in a rightly scared voice, after all, he tied his future with them, and although Horde Ultimate was better than his insane brother, he still had a lot of blood on his hands.

"We will attack him with all our strength and crush him before he can prepare." growled her dearest, and she smiled tenderly at him, sometimes he was so... simple.

"For political reasons it would not be wise. If he represents the Pact Worlds and Veskarium , an attack on him could lead to war with them, and we are not in the least ready for it. Moreover, perhaps thanks to him we will form an alliance with Veskarium, which will help us win the war and protect us from the more sinister forces lurking in the galaxy."

"More sinister forces?" asked the Seneschal, almost biting his tail.

"For example, the Azlanti Star Empire." she said with absolute seriousness.

Seleste smiled at her servant, who was Vlaka a highly social wolf-like humanoid from the slowly freezing planet Lajok. They where once a thug who attacked defenseless non-humans until the Star Empire captured him and subjected him to re-education, the only trace of which was a small scar on his forehead... They became a good servant, and the congenital deafness was another of their many advantages. She will need all the help she can get on this momentous mission given to her by the Star Twins. She will bring the Law of Humanity to this godforsaken corner of the Galaxy!

Unlike many citizens of the Empire, she did not consider the Non-humans to be inferior, just different, biologically adapted to different tasks, and Humanity was to make sure that everyone found the best place for themselves, so that they would be happy. The Empire thus achieved a perfect harmony that was the envy of the Empire by lesser and more primitive civilizations, either mired in the Chaos of Diversity and Equality, or ruled by definitionally nefarious non-human rulers. Although the Star Empire was powerful, even it was unable to fight against so many treacherous opponents, and the galaxy was still plunged in darkness and ignorance. Fortunately, once her mission succeeds, and she didn't even consider any other outcome, everything will change and there will be peace and prosperity in the galaxy.

They reached the outskirts of the Ravaged Zone and began reconnaissance. What the Expeditionary Fleet under her command found was terrifying in the hearts of righteous humans. An entire region of the Galaxy was devastated by a nefarious Non-Human tyrant who was destroying planets inhabited not only by harmless Non-Human creatures, but even local factions of the human species. Was there a greater meanness? The quintessence of his madness was recognizing himself as a perfect being. For such a blasphemous statement alone, he deserved the Empire to send a crusade against him, not to mention the other crimes he committed against both Humans and their minor brothers. This place was the best proof that the Imperial Way was right and that all alternatives lead to darkness.

She sighed and put down her cup of tea, absolutely perfect as always, and looked at the star chart. The non-human tyrant who used the name of Horde Prime was finally annihilated, which was easy to predict, after all, alien empires always fell sooner or later without the enlightened guidance of the human species, or fell into decadence, because the non-humans surrendered much more easily to their primitive impulses than her species. However, why he fell was much more interesting. From what could be inferred from the first actual message coming from the Zone, he was killed by the Lady of Chaos and her terrible entourage, but it was delivered by a Drow women, a member of one of the most

untrustworthy non-human species. Was there any point in considering the words of this type of creature? And besides, she had her own, much more reliable source of information on this subject. She looked at the trunk where she kept her greatest treasure, "The Song of Eternity" by Sereni, Mara's Friend . This document, along with several others, was one of the main reasons for organizing this expedition. Although not the only one. She looked at her face reflected in the porcelain saucer, the sight of it will fill the hearts of the inhabitants of the place to which they were heading with joy. N*ot the most important reason indeed*. She thought at the sight and smiled.

"I think it's time to make a speech." she said to the soldier who was her personal guard. She went to the Communications Room of "Sovereign Vindicator " class dreadnought called " Destiny " and began to speak to all participants of the expedition, both human and non-human brethren.

"We came here together, regardless of our biological origins, to bring the light of our great Empire to this dark place. For millennia it has lived in the shadow of Tyranny, whose deeds were so terrible that the crimes of Veskarium and the Pact Worlds pale in comparison ! Although he was defeated, his evil did not go away with him and it is our moral duty to eradicate it by all available means! However, it is not only the inner desire to bring justice that has led us to Ravaged Zone. There is a unique planet here called Etheria. It is a planet imbued with magic like no other place in the Galaxy, where the Second Star Stone is found. This is one of the most powerful artifacts in the Galaxy, which once raised four people to godhood, including Aroden , the Last Azlanti, not without reason called the god of humanity. Until recently we believed that there is only one, which is kept, against all laws established by humans and gods, on the Absalom station and used to power it. However, there is another one on Etheria as if the gods themselves, in their infinite graciousness, had given us another one to use for the good and glory of the Human species. But there is something else, for thousands of years ago there was the heart of the great Empire of the First Ones. Contrary to the disgusting political correctness and false propaganda of the Pact

Worlds, they were not machines, but faction of humanity who had achieved such an incredible level of technology that the deeds of our great empire pale in comparison. They greatest heroine was She-Ra, an incarnate goddess who fought tirelessly to fulfill the destiny of the Human species. Although the previous She-Ra sacrificed herself to give her people a chance against countless nefarious inhuman enemies, she has now been reborn. Elementary logic indicates that she is none other than the Lady of Chaos indicated by that non-human woman in this false propaganda message. It was she who defeated Horde Prime, and I am absolutely certain that once we reach her, remind her of her glorious heritage, show her the glory of our Great Empire, she will support our cause and share with us all her might, and we will bring about Pax Azlantica first in this galaxy, then in the entire universe!" she shouted, her voice filled with triumph

Kane felt a general disdain for vampires. Not because they were dead, blood-sucking parasites, although of course they were. He had no such prejudices. The problem was that only a true fool willingly became one. When you turned into a vampire, you were inactive for a large part of the day. While a human could work at night, doing anything at the day, was a problem for many vampires. Moreover, they depended on the blood of intelligent beings. Before the invention of synthetic substitutes, the hunt itself often took many hours. And their potential victims were not only able to defend themselves, but also actively searched for night predators. All this in exchange for some, rather interesting, he had to admit, powers and the illusory promise of immortality. The bitter truth was that in most cases Vampires did not exist for more than two or three years, being at this time only pathetic minions of their more powerful creators. In his unimaginably long life, he had the opportunitie to become one of these beings, but he always refused. Although perhaps because of his long life, his perspective was slightly distorted...

But Doctor Sidonius was the exception to this rule. He became undead against his will due to an accident on Lost Golarion. It was

a long time ago, and he used his extraordinarily long life to expand his knowledge. A goal that was definitely more noble than sitting in a ruined castle and pretending to be a dark lord until someone finally found that would be great to slay fucking bloodsucker and becoming a hero. Of course, he had another thing in common with the doctor... longevity... Just like with his other companion, Prince Zed .

He had no memory of Automaton's arrival on Carurystal.. There was nothing strange about it. Though he was not affected by the Gap as severely as most mortals, his memories of the past millennia were cloudy, pitted, and mixed. Only unlike Doctor Sidonius, he was happy with this state of affairs. However, he knew that Prince Zed was connected to all the events that caused him to leave Carurystal, his eternal sanctum The Doctor didn't pretend to be trustworthy, but Prince Zed was always nice, polite and jovial. He hated such people with all his heart.

The three of them sat at a round table made of a substance of pearl like structure. There was a permanent coffee pot, intended only for him, no one else drank here... at least not normal substances...

“We managed to intercept the signal sent to the Lord Admiral by my Agent.” said the old Vampire, showing his long fangs in a triumphant smile.

"But doesn't that mean his loyalty may now lie with someone else?" Prince Zed asked.

Good point

“To put it bluntly, he sold himself to someone stronger.” he said in a hard voice, clenching his fists. The doctor shrugged.

“Does it matter? For this type of person, talking about loyalty is pointless. He will probably just try to get as much as possible for himself. He will play both or more sides, but we will benefit most

from the information he provides.” explained the scientist, looking at his nails.

“What about your old friend Antares ?” he growled.

“As far as I know the Lord Admiral, he won't be interested in ancient mysteries and archaeological curiosities. Whatever weapons were on Etheria are now inactive, and there is nothing left on this planet of interest to him. We just need to keep our heads down and do our job and everything will go our way.” he said, but Kane had the impression that the Vampire had assured them far too quickly of the Lord Admiral's lack of interest in Etheria. For the time being, he allowed Sidonius to keep certain facts secret… For now.

“The Lord Admiral's possible plans are not our main concern now. For now, we need to decide what we will do after arriving on Etheria.” said Prince Zed, making a gesture as if he was grabbing his mustache. The doctor smiled, showing his fangs.

“We will lie low and observe the development of the situation, waiting for the right moment to step into action and take the initiative. This is what I've always been best at.”

He smiled at the ancient scholar and looked at him with his cold blue eyes

“Then I'll kill things, I'm pretty good at that too.”

Lady Ka and the Lord Admiral walked through the corridors of the heavy cruiser Invincible .

“Everything is ready to departure or continue the war. So far, no news of our victory has reached us or no one has taken appropriate action. Unfortunately, my intelligence network in this area is minimal at the moment, but we are working hard to create It won't be that difficult, because all settlements established outside the planets now exist practically on their own. There is

such Chaos and Lawlessness in the Deep Space that the first person with enough power and wealth will gain obedience there.” she said, nervously flipping through the sheets of paper.

“Well, you know it best. I suspect that most of the local warlords, including She- Ra, are too focused on their own affairs to ever consider what lies beyond the empire. Their ignorance plays to our advantage. However, we need to gain allies. We need to organize a delegation to this halfling planet Bellum. The locals have a lot of troops and are willing to fight. Take care of it.”

She nodded, made a mental note of the instruction, and continued.

“The interim government will start working soon. At the first sitting of Parliament, a bill proclaiming you Lord Protector will be voted on, completely spontaneously and independently. Hooray! Then all that's left is to organize a parade and we can fly to Etheria. Only that Shiren girl from social media, Ashurk, wants to come with us. On the one hand, she's terribly annoying, but on the other hand, additional positive PR would be useful. At most, if we can't get enough of her, some terrible accident will happen to her. I'm really good at making up terrible accidents.” she explained, and the Lor Admiral nodded to her. They walked in silence for a while until they finally reached the lock. There were about ten clones standing behind the glass doors.

“These boys made a lot of trouble. They attacked the guards and even killed two. Lady Ka said, standing at the lever. The Lord Admiral looked at the face of his pocket watch and asked in a slightly bored voice.

“So you're not going to stop fighting.”

One of the clones looked at him defiantly and said in a voice full of exaltation.

“You Fools! Our death and life don't matter! Horde Prime is testing us and is waiting to return and punish those whose faith was

weak.

The Lord Admiral grimaced in disgust.

“If you say so” he said and started to leave On the way, he gave Lady Ka a significant look. She waited until his footsteps quieted down and said.

"Orders not given, crimes not done."

And she pulled the lever.

Asindesa di Vir looked thoughtfully at her blade, reading the inscription on it over and over again. “End of Eternity – Blade of Vengeance.” Here, in Horde Prime's former Empire, this name rang a special bell. She led an assault on fortified enemy positions to bring... freedom to those who had been enslaved for half a century by the most insane tyrant in the galaxy. She fought to avenge the billions of beings he had wiped out. To avenge her planet and her family, even though she barely remembered it... However, she had no one to take revenge on. Horde Prime was dead, and his clones were just hapless beings who refused to accept the truth of their Big Brother's fate. The Order's mission on this expedition has effectively come to an end. There was no existential threat, so hellknights were not needed. She could think of something else now. During his meeting with his Star Siblings, the Lord Admiral seemed to show a surprising interest in Etheria's affairs. It was an excuse for her. She also intended to go to that place. To keep an eye on Lord Antares, of course

“The ship is ready. Are you sure you want to go there?” Camila asked

She responded with a warm smile.

“Yes, this time I will take care of my own future, my own happiness.”

Welcome to Etheria

“Well, let's get out of Dryft . Three. Two. One.” Bina counted down, and Rosie gripped the arms of the chair tightly. She was excited. They were all excited. Even Eti was wagging her tail nervously. Finally, the entire ship shuddered slightly and an image of the planet appeared on the main cockpit monitor.

“There's no sun, just like the maps said. You know, the darkness between the stars and that sort of thing.” Doctor Quin muttered. Rosie looked at Etheria's image. She looked quite normal. It had one green-blue continent, and a lot of moons.

“Seems quite alright to me. It certainly looks like a much nicer place than Akiton”

Ysoka gave her an offended look.

“What do you have against Akiton ! It's a very nice planet!

Alatar snorted.

“Akiton looks like a litter box that no one has cleaned, and it's even worse up close.”

Eti looked at Alatar suspiciously, but she caught on to the joke and began to speak in a serious voice.

“Sages say that when devils come across an extremely sinful soul, they bring it before Asmodeus himself, the prince of darkness , to judge it. She usually sends them to one of the circles of hell to receive a special, individual punishment. However, sometimes he encounters so of a hardened sinner, that there is no place for them in hell nor in Abbys or even in Abbadon. Then he makes a decision that even his dark heart is to afraid to make and sends her to a place that is terrifying even among the lords of hell... AKITON.”

Wrongdak blinked twice in surprise.

“Is this such a scary place?” he asked with surprise.

Itel grimaced.

“Not really, it's just that in this place there are metropolises full of gangsters and endless stretches of desert ruled by bandits. And all this is watered with the bitter sauce of decay and hopelessness.” she said with a very sour smile on her face. Since yesterday's conversation with Eti, the solarian was clearly depressed. Her... Their feline friend, on the other hand, seemed happier and somehow calmer. However, she had the impression that the elf was also worried about this, although she didn't quite know why.

“But their kebab is great.” Lilka interjected. Eti nodded and said.

“Its’s tastes great, although it's made of rats ... but still tastes great.”

Everyone nodded at her.

“Is there Kebab on Etheria?” Lilka asked with great interest, and the clone looked at them in surprise.

“I'm not sure, I usually ate at my friend Entrapta's , and she only prepared things in small portions, and you can't prepare kebabs that way... But I ate delicious dumplings. They were made from what was found on Darla... It's a First One ship.” he explained and smiled at his memories.

“Wait, these aren't starlings? Didn't they become extinct several thousand years ago? Have you accidentally eaten archaeological treasures?” Alatar asked suspiciously. Wrongdak shrugged.

“Maybe so, but it was the most delicious thing I've ever eaten and the first thing I ate after amino acids. Then I spent the whole day in the toilet. I thought it was Horde Prime punishing me for my transgression... Glimmer and I prepared them together... Queen Glimmer”

“I guess we can't count on the queen cooking for us, right?” Rosie asked curiously. She's already met a few princesses, that's quite a lot... But not a queen... Although she think Adora called Captain Moonshadow Queen...

“Okay, kids, no more chatting. It's time to contact someone from the spaceport, space traffic control or at least some guard, because they're about to shoot us down because they have enough firepower to blow up cruiser.” Bina said and pointed to the projected image, which showed spaceships. They looked like things built by the Horde... Only they were so colorful. They looked quite nice, but also dangerous. And there was a big tree floating around the planet, like the thirteenth moon, only tiny. Looking at this sight, Eti turned her head to the side and said.

“Who commands them? These ships are arranged in no order, this is not what a defensive formation looks like... Is there anyone out there who knows how to command a space fleet? And what is this tree about? This all makes absolutely no sense.”

“Then tell them yourself, they'll probably hire you. – Bina said and muttered a curse word that the glasses didn't show. - Do not even think about it! Okay, now be quiet because I'm entering the communication channel.” the captain cleared her throat and continued. “This is Captain Bina from the ship.” she sighed heavily. “Deadly Sword of Burning Fury. We ask for permission to arrive on Etheria and designate a suitable place in the spaceport, or if this is not possible, indicate a suitable place for landing.”

After a while, someone from the staff spoke up.

“Hello. This is Stefani, cybernetic assistant to Chief Space Traffic Controller Entrapta . Unfortunately, she is currently on an extremely important scientific mission and is unavailable at this time, but I will be happy to take care of you. I am sending you a list of available landing sites. If you need any more help, please ask. I will be very happy to help you. And I invite everyone to the Victory Day celebrations organized on the occasion of the fifth anniversary of the victory over Horde Prime and the double

wedding of Queen Glimmer and She-Ra, the heroine of the galaxy.” the voice fell silent

“Yeah... that's nice... we need to discuss where we will land, but as soon as we make a decision, we will let you know...” Bina said and smiled at Wrongdak friendly. “Your friend's assistant has a pretty sexy voice.”

Arkan-tar smiled as he looked at the map of Etheria, although he felt no joy at all. He was just putting on a good face for a bad game... No, he had done that before. Not it was more of a game whose rules he didn't understand, but he tried very hard to pretend that he knew what was going on. Even though he was a good trickster, constantly pretending to be smarter than he was, was beyond him.

It was strange, but the fact that Etheria wasn't such a terrible place didn't calm him down at all. He could find himself in unpleasant places, much worse than Saltmarsh, although not as bad as the Lady of Chaos's domain was supposed to be. It wasn't even about the fact that he looked like a fool who fell for cheap propaganda, even though his ego was hurt. He just felt like he was on the wrong side. He had often broken the law and stolen cultural goods from other civilizations and cheated his partners, but now he realized that he was involved in matters much bigger than acquiring treasures. He worked for an ancient vampire and supported a ruthless, cruel dictator in his terrible plans. When the locals find out what he did, they will be, to put it bluntly, screwed. They will have as an enemy someone who could fight personally with a warship and win easily. And then there were all her friends who were just as powerful... Not to mention the fact that they had brought in Captain Moonshadow, who in some completely inexplicable way turned out to be a queen from Etheria, and she had a beef with the damn demigoddess about it. Like Rechiza, when he saw this, he just stood there and prayed very hard to all the devils and demons that they would not accuse them of complicity. They didn't, which was so contrary to everything he

had learned about how governments and rulers worked that he felt his neck several times to make sure that She-Ra wasn't beheading him when he blinked. Well, at least he wasn't Azlanti. He wouldn't want to be in one of their shoes when they meet Adora or the Queen.

He himself wondered why he was still on this mission. There was, of course, money that Doctor Sidonius paid him, very much money, with which he would probably have lived the rest of his days in comfort and prosperity, but for this to happen, they both had to survive this expedition, what wasn’t obvious. Undead and demigoddesses of light weren't a very good combination... or maybe too good, depending on side you look at it... The weapon, from what he could gather, had been destroyed. At least that's what they said at Clytemnestra, they'll have to find out more on the spot anyway to be sure. Even if it was, they would have to make sure it couldn’t be rebuilt, or if the planet didn't hold any more dark secrets, which Doctor Sidonius had said was certain...

But what really drew him to this planet was Lady Cala's story, the prospect of them finding Eternia, the true capital of the First Ones, was a temptation he couldn't resist. He wanted to be rich, who wouldn't? But wealth could be acquired in many ways. He knew deep in his heart that he was looking for something else. The immortal fame that would come with discovering the home planet of one of the most mysterious and highly developed civilizations that lived in the galaxy. He did meet Adora who, in her natural form, did not make a great impression, to put it mildly. But she was raised on an underdeveloped and provincial planet that had been cut off from the rest of the galaxy for millennia, having little in common with her highly developed relatives... Of course, it was more than likely that Eternia was no longer inhabited and the girl had come from some another, unknown place... But it was even better this way... All the treasures and secrets of the First Ones would then be at his fingertips, only for him.

They were standing in the navigation room. Miss Daisy, Lady Cala, Rechiza, Dilayla, Wrongdak, Doctor Quin , and of course Bina, who had not broken her connection with Susan, were observing

Etheri'as map. He wondered more and more what the captain and her young crew had in mind in flying here. What were they looking for here, and who was this mysterious friend the kids were talking about, and most importantly, why didn't Doctor Sidonius fill him in on it? Did he consider him an untrustworthy person?... Okay, he was completely right in this case, but why did he prefer to entrust such an important mission to a clone woman who was a gang member and a bunch of unstable kids, rather than someone with a certain reputation, maybe not the most clean one, but at least he knew what to expect from him.

"Okay, so yes. The landing zones that can accept us are: Brightmoon, Sea Gate, Winter City, Joy Zone, Crimson Waste, Stormvale, United Kingdom Court, Beast Island, Sorcerer's Hollow , and Rainfall. Unfortunately, they don't have a spaceport here , but I understand they want to build one in this tree." Bina paused, but Wrongdak began to explain.

"It was Velvet Glove , flagship of Horde Prime. That's where I was born - when he saw everyone looking at him in surprise, he added. "He used to look completely different."

Bina nodded and Rechiza asked smiling sarcastically.

"Since Mr. Wrongdak has been on Etheri for so long and has become acquainted with so many distinguished people, perhaps he will tell us a little about this planet and help us choose a place where we will stay?"

The Clone almost blushed, apparently not catching the sarcasm in Lashunti voice. He leaned over the map and, pointing to subsequent places, began to tell the story.

"Brightmpoon is the capital of the kingdom of Etheri. Here live Queen Glimmer, Bow, Adora and... " he exchanged glances with Bina. "…and the rest. "On Beast Island Entrapta live with my brother. She used to live in Castle Crypto in Dryll, near Storm Valley..."

At this point, Stefani interjected.

“Dryll has not been part of the Etheri Kingdom for some time now and if you land there, we will not be able to ensure your safety.”

“Good to know Stefani, you can continue Wrongdak.” Bina said, and the white-skinned alien continued talking.

“The Joy Zone used to be the Fright Zone and my brother ruled it, but now Scorpia rules there... You met her and her wife Perfuma. The Sorcerer's Valley is near Mystacor , a school for Sorcerers, that is, mystics. Aunt Casta, the one who made me this sweater, lives there.” He pointed to his strange clothes. “The Sea Gate is ruled by Mermista , Winter City is near the Ice Palace belonging to Princess Frosta... That's all I know. I didn't get to know this planet well because I hadn’t lived here too long and i was rather busy getting to know myself.” Wrongdak seemed a bit embarrassed, but Bina smiled warmly at him and asked, pointing to the great desert near the Joy Zone

“There are The Crimson Wastes. It's not a pleasant place, it's full of violence and lawlessness, although Huntara may have brought some order there recently In the Valley of the Lost, until recently, you could buy anything and no one asked for anything.” the clone explained with slight concern. Bina bared her teeth in a radiant smile.

“Sounds like Akiton!”

Wrongdak frowned in confusion.

“But I think you said today that that planet is a terrible place.”

The Captain waved her hand.

“Yeah, it's terrible, no doubt about it, but you know, it's terrible in the way we know and have become accustomed to. Better the familiar Abyss than the alien Nirvana.”

“However, I would like to mention that it is a very dangerous place, and its inhabitants are definitely not nice and law-abiding people.” Stefani said in a concerned voice. “Brightmoon would probably suit you much better!”

Bina smiled slyly and said.

“Honey, don't teach charlatan to cheat suckers, a few thugs won't be able to handle us , and now we, but we have private matters to discuss. Bye.” she said and disconnected the call, then turned to the others.

“Well, my dears, the situation is as Mr. Wrongdak described to you. I suggest that we land in the Scarlet Wastes, because it's a neutral place where no one cares about anyone else's hands, and money can buy anything, and money is what we have. I also suspect that all the treasure hunters and adventurers like that are there.”

Then Arkan-tar bowed low and spoke in a polite, somewhat formal tone.

“I think it's time for our two expeditions to separate. I'm looking for things that are similar, but slightly different.” he was explaining, but Lady Cala interrupted him.

“Perhaps it's worth not cutting off contact completely. As Arkan-tar said, our goals are quite similar and in my opinion we should exchange information and help each other. I understand you are looking for one specific item, while our interests are much more scientific in nature... although I won't be a prude and say that we would also be happy with treasures. Maybe we will meet during the celebration of this victory day. Your young pupils will certainly want to have fun during such a joyful event, and we will be able to exchange information without arousing suspicion. Who knows, maybe we will be able to win Adora, the Queen and the other princesses to our cause, or at least convince them to help us.”

Bina exchanged glances with Wrongdak . He saw concern in the captain's eyes, and a request in the clone's eyes... Very interesting

“I'm not sure if this is really a good idea, my kids are terrible wildings after all.”

Lady Cala, however, responded with a warm, friendly smile.

“Oh, you should believe in them more. They are good and resourceful kids, I'm sure they will cope. They have already managed to make friends with Adora and other princesses.”

Miss Daisy looked at her sternly, that was also interesting, but on the other hand, could this drunkard be hiding a secret worth knowing?

Bina sighed and said.

“I'll think about it. But I'm taking Rosie with me. No offense, but apart from Dilala and Miss Daisy, you don't really care about her, and my kids are friends with her”

Dr. Quin snorted disdainfully.

“Everyone would care much more if the girl wasn't so lazy and did what we all pay her to do.”

He threw up his arms. The girl was nice and could fight, which was very surprising, but she wasn't really needed.

“If she agrees, I don't see a problem.” replied the captain. Then Miss Daisy came to the map and said.

“Since we're all splitting up, I'd like to ask to be taken to several places. First, maybe we'll take Wrongdak to Beast Island to meet his brother, and then we'll visit Mystacor, I used to be a magic teacher and I'm curious what magical education is like here. Then I'll check out Brightmoon and see what the situation is there. Maybe I'll meet someone from society.”

Trunks of Etheria written by the hand of Miss Daisy, who was personally acquainted with each of them. He thought, smiling ironically.

Bina nodded.

“Okay, just take my kids to Brightmoon, let them see a bit of normal life...”

Dilayla turned pale when she heard these words. Strange, she's had a problem with Lady Cala so far . But he'll talk to her about it later... if he decides it's worth doing. if he decides it's worth taking care of?

“Miss Daisy, you may be an outstanding Sorcerer, but I'm not sure if you should go alone to a strange place... Completely unknown and alien. – the mercenary suddenly said , with very badly feigned concern in her voice, and the gloomy mystic replied with a cunning smile.

“Of course, you're right, my dear, that's why I decided to take Ireanis with me.”

Bina and Dilayla blinked in confusion.

“You know, traveling with Ireanis is almost the same as traveling alone, or even worse, it's like traveling with a child of Chaos. “ Bina said carefully.

“As I said, you should have more faith in your Wards...”said Miss Daisy.

“Did someone sleep with someone here and I didn't notice anything?” He thought, but then Dr. Quin tapped some keys and overlaid some data on the map.

“This planet is scientifically amazing, in my opinion someone should evict all the inhabitants from here and start full- scale scientific research... “ Ysoka coughed and, seeing people looking at her, she added. “Yes, the planet is as full of holes as cheese...

No speciesist associations, please. It almost looks like the whole thing is a huge ultra-advanced structure. Unfortunately, our scanners cannot obtain much data because of this. However, I found some places where the structure of the planet was disturbed.” she pointed to several colorful dots. Lady Cala leaned forward and said.

“Two of these points are near the Crimson Wasteland. One is at the junction of the Wasteland, Brightmoon and the Zone of Joy, the other is near a place called the Singing Jungle... I think we'll visit the Jungle first, then we'll look at places closer to the capital. Are you comfortable with this arrangement?” asked the aristocrat, looking at them carefully. He threw up his arms.

“That's fine with me. I don't know what the rest think. ”He looked at Rechiza significantly. The Warper had been strangely moody since the events at Clytemnestra.

“Yes, it all sounds... Reasonable, you should always follow the voice of reason...” said Lashunti, strangely unfamiliar voice.

An hour later they entered the atmosphere. It happened without any problems. Landing was much more difficult because the landing pad was just smooth rock. Fortunately, the piloting skills of Alatar, Bina and Mr. Ilemshaw were so high that nothing happened, not even shaking them badly. Or maybe she didn't feel it clearly. She was too distracted and at the same time absolutely focused on the task ahead of her. She tried not to let on that she was aware of Miss Daisy's identity, that she was much more than just the annoying aristocrat's tutor. Everything now fell into place logically. Her participation in this mission, magical power completely incompatible with the position she held... Her weird attitude towards Eti, this strange protectiveness in someone with such a decisive and strict character. She had to do something about it... But she couldn't count on her companions' help. Arkantar probably just shrugged and said he couldn't do anything. This individual didn't even mind that he worked for a war criminal who

used nuclear weapons against his own planet. And Lady Cala, this woman must have known the truth about Miss Daisy, After all, she entrusted her with the management of the estate... This whole expedition must have been the idea of the dark mystic, although it did not absolve the Aristocrat. Whoever cooperated with the monster became part of it himself. That's why she had to do what was needed even more. Not only to save Bina and the kids, but also to save herself.

When they landed, she was already clad in power armor while they were on the ground. Everyone went outside to get some fresh air. Two local people were taking care of the landing site. Four- Armed Lizard and Satyr Woman. As soon as they left, the horned one turned to them with a cunning smile.

“We're only here to pay for guarding the ship... To make sure nothing happens to it.”

Dilayla didn't want to argue. She simply took the red stone and crushed it in her armored hand. They both turned pale at the sight and politely swept the sand away. Miss Daisy had walked quite a distance and seemed surprised amazingly relaxed. She smiled to herself, it was a significant relief. She moved towards the woman with a grim smile. She wasn't sure if the others would understand, especially Rosie, but she couldn't help it... Maybe when she was older...

She wasn't able to sneak in her armor, so she just walked towards it, trying to make her steps sound neutral. She had to get as close as possible to strike a blow before the other could cast her spell. But before she was far enough away, Miss Daisy said.

“Even if you succeeded, the only thing you would achieve would be to make Lady Cala happy.”

She stopped in surprise and the gloomy Elf turned to her with a smile on her face

“You've been lying to everyone from the beginning. You're from here...” she said angrily, but without shouting, so as not to attract the attention of the rest, and the sorceress nodded.

“My name was Shadow Weaver, and before that I was called Light Spinner. I was a war criminal. I hurt and betrayed everyone I knew. I finally did the only good thing in my life and sacrificed myself for my daughters, Adora and Catra. But I did not receive the grace of death and now I am here.”

She blinked a few times, but then shook her head.

“So that's why you're so fascinated by Eti... This girl also resembles the daughter whom, according to Wrongdak, you hurt so much. What are you looking for in her? Redemption for what a mean and lousy bitch you were? – she said in a venomous tone. However, the gloomy elf only smiled bitterly.

“I know it's ridiculous. I know perfectly well, but... I couldn't resist. Don't you know what it's like to believe that you have lost everything, leaving behind only memories full of pain and anger, and then to be given a second chance to do everything again, this time better, without making the same mistakes?”

Dilayla laughed darkly.

“So why did you come to this place? As far as I know, everyone here hates you, you have no friends or allies here. You could go anywhere in the Galaxy, do absolutely anything you wanted. With your talent and skills... You were free, and instead you came to the only place that doesn't want you. Why!?

This time it was Miss Daisy who laughed. She heard a lot of pain and sadness in that laughter.

“No, I'm not free.” she approached her. “I cannot tell you the details, but know that the game is about something much bigger than you, me or even the dammed Lord Admiral. We are all mere pawns in a game that began thousands of years ago, but unfortunately its end will unfold before our eyes.” She stood in

front of Dilayla so that he could kiss her. “You can kill me. Even though I am much more powerful here on Etheria than I was recently, I will let you try to kill me. But know that if I die, no one will stop Lady Cali from... doing what she wants. And what she wants most is to bathe in blood.”

Dilayla stared into the dark mystic's emerald green eyes for a moment, until she lowered her gaze and moved out of the dark sorceress's way.

“Okay, now I have to talk to Ireanis like a drunkard to a drunkard.” Miss Daisy or Shadow Weaver said and moved towards Papa. She watched her go for a moment until she suddenly saw Rosie running towards her. The deaf girl hugged her as tightly as her armor would allow and then spoke in Sign Language.

“Bina said I would go with them if I wanted to. I... I like Eti... and the others. But we are friends and... be careful.”

She gently stroked the girl's head and said.

“Don't worry. A tough girl like me won't be hurt by anything.”

She woke up... or rather was woken up by a splash of cold water in her face. She jumped to her feet abruptly, summoning some kind of spell. She wasn't exactly sure what it was, but it was TERRIBLE. Through her she saw Miss... Dandy... Danny ... Daisy! She liked her. She drank with her and didn't judge, at least not like others did. She was a good friend. But then she saw something that chilled her heart.

“Nooo!” she exclaimed and ran to the empty bottles standing by the sink in her cabin. – You did the best thing! – she screamed as she felt tears flowing down her face.

“Something what someone should have done a long time ago. Bina is a good woman, but she did wrong to let you get drunk like a fish day after day.”

“But... What will I do now?” The Sorceress from Mwangi said in a dead voice. Miss Daisy put her hand on her shoulder and smiled warmly and said.

“I won't cheat on you. Will be hard. But we will be in this together. We must have clear and agile minds to face what lies ahead. But we can do it.”

She looked at the mystic with sadness.

“I can barely face the morning. I'm just a pathetic drunkard.”

Miss Daisy nodded and said.

“But you were a much better person… Better than I ever was. And I will help you become that person again.”

Blood on the crimson sand

“I don't like these birds,” said Eti, looking at the sky.

“You never like birds. It's probably some form of paranoia, you know?” Itel answered her.

Eti looked towards her, stroking Toshi's head, whom they had taken with them again, and said in a slightly more energetic voice than usual.

“You know, you shouldn't accuse me of being paranoid.” there was a note of excitement with a pinch of irritation in her tone. She didn't like it. She sensed that something dread was approaching, that the darkness in Eti's soul was awakening. It was always a sign of something bad and terrible… She wasn't sure what had triggered it, but now they had to be very careful not to leave the girl alone. Did Bina notice this… and should she have noticed? Then he would lock them in the ship and tell her to keep an eye on Eti... Maybe she should do it as a good friend... But she had a mission and Eti was essential to its success... She looked at Rosie, who was looking doubtfully at the birds flying above their heads. "Besides, Eti now has a new friend... Not everything has to be on my shoulders" she thought bitterly. She knew she was being unfair to this deaf girl, but she couldn't help it... But she fought with herself, she tried damn hard to be objective.

“Eti, we're not talking about me now, we're talking about your damn obsession with birds. They didn't do anything to you. It was the same on Saltmarsh and everywhere...” she said slowly, trying to sound calm, but then Eti interrupted her.

“This is an obvious and terrible lie. Not everywhere birds seem suspicious to me. For example, there in the monastery no one looked suspicious…”

“Because there weren't any birds there...” he tried not to lose his temper, but then the cat girl stopped her from finishing again.

“I don't see any connection between the fact that there were no birds there and the fact that I didn't suspect them of anything. Non-existent birds are just as suspicious, maybe even more so. You know, once again you're showing off your complete lack of logical thinking. Besides, I didn't suspect any on Icarus, and maybe I should have... Then he wouldn't have caused this scandal with Captain Wingy ... And yes, I liked her, and yet she was a bit bird-like.

“You should suspect her, we all should...” she said with resignation. She rubbed her forehead, she was tired, and they had just left the ship. Did they make Bina feel this way?

Their captain was talking to the strange couple guarding the landing pad. Dilayla and the others had already packed and decided to use the local communicator to call for some form of transport. After learning that the armored mercenary was leaving them, lizard and the goat women became more cunny and now Bina had to show them their place. Itel ordered the others to approach the arguing trio.

“What? So I have to pay you to wash the ship, otherwise I will be fined for disfiguring the landscape?” The burgundy-haired woman said, smiling skeptically

“What can you do, it's the law. Fifty Etherian swords are due.”

“How much?” Bina exclaimed indignantly. The goat woman spread her arms and said in an almost apologetic tone.

“You know, it's desert here, there's no water, costs are rising.”

“Yeah, maybe you can show me the appropriate regulation, law or decree, or something else that the queens do there. Please i want to see it.” Bina said, and all cheerfulness disappeared from her face. Perhaps the horned women would have continued to argue, but then there was a loud " Zap ", then " Skree ", and one of the

birds fell onto the scarlet sands, shrouded in clouds of smoke. Everyone's eyes turned towards Eti. The cat girl was still dressed in her Akytonian nomadic garb, quite fitting for the place, but there was still something menacing about her posture. She rested her head on her shoulder and began to speak in a surprisingly sweet and cheerful voice. In a voice that didn't quite match her words.

"You know what? Maybe we'll pay you with chicken soup. And tomorrow there will be goat stew and lizard soup." she approached them and revealed her beautiful face, which she could stare at for hours, if only she was allowed to… And she continued her statement. "Although the goat stew requires some turnips and shallots, and the lizard stew would need some chili, but I'm sure it can be sorted out." she didn't stop moving closer to them as she spoke until she was close enough to the pair of smartasses that she could look them straight in the eye. They seemed terrified, though she had the impression that it wasn't the cat girl's words but the sight of her face that frightened them more. It was disturbing…

"And you know what, there are definitely some loopholes in the law, right?" the horned one said in a fearful voice, and her lizard companion quickly nodded.

And then something unexpected happened. Eti smiled. This sight would be wonderful if it weren't so terrible. Eti placed a metal hand on the horned woman's shoulder

"And you know what? I am absolutely certain that there is a law of hospitality that requires the first inhabitants of this planet we meet to wash our ship , with dire penalties for failure to comply, but you are law-abiding citizens and you will wash our ship out of the pure goodness of your hearts."

Now the two of them had a look of pure horror on their faces. They nodded in silence.

“See Bina? This is how you should negotiate!” Eti exclaimed happily, wagging the tip of her tail.

Bina looked at them seriously.

“March to Crushey.” she said in an emotionless voice.

“I'd like to meet the guy who designed it. He had to have a smart head on his shoulders, don't you think?” said Eti, pointing to the anti-gravity vehicle in which Lady Cala and her group were flying away. Bina saw a poorly repainted Horde symbol, red this time, although the vehicle was very crude compared to the creations of the galactic Horde. She looked at the Crusher, which, painted absurdly by her kids and covered with scars from the War, didn't look like a fancy machine itself, but it had served them well over the years, so she hoped this construction would not disappoint Lady Cala and her companions.

It turned out that this pair of sly guys ran some kind of stall or shop and sold desert clothes, suspicious-looking food, water and maps. She took the map and extra water and even paid for them, although after Eti intimidated them, she could have taken everything she wanted and they would probably have given her all their property. The cat girl could be disturbingly scary, though something told her that she hadn't succeeded this time just because of her talent.

“Okay gang, listen to me because I'm too lazy to repeat myself.” she said, standing next to the armored carrier. “Since our ship is leaving to carry Wrongdak and Miss Daisy, I'm taking you with me… That doesn't mean I wouldn't take you anyway, because let's be honest, you wouldn't listen to me anyway, right?” She asked rhetorically and pointed at Crusher. “We're going to the Valley of the Lost, the largest settlement in the Crimson Wastes. We'll split up there. Itel with Eti and Rosie will look for a place called Bone Haven, it's some kind of bar or inn or something, and Itel with Rosie will ask the locals there, and our shooter will insure her

from afar. Meanwhile, I'll take a look around the town and see what I can find out. Only Itel, remember that no one can be harmed. Keep an eye on them, okay?" she asked the Elf, and instead of arguing, she obediently nodded, which confirmed her suspicions that things weren't going well with the cat girl. She wondered if she should lock Eti in the armored carrier, but she couldn't be trapped without using drastic methods, and that would only make the situation worse. She preferred to put the girl in a chosen place where she wouldn't have the opportunity to do anything stupid and count on Itel and Rosie to keep an eye on her... or four at once.

They got into Crusher and set off.

"Crimson Wastes, fear my roar!" exclaimed Crusher and laughed sinisterly.

"Crush, maybe this i we could start our visit to an new planet without intimidating everyone around us." she asked in a resigned voice.

"But Eti could! Why was she allowed and not me? Is it because she has a tail." asked the transporter.

"Yes, it's because she has a tail." she explained. *Why do my kids have to be so murderous?* she asked herself. Rosie sat down next to her and stared at her for a moment, until she finally asked in a hushed voice, or rather with hushed gloves.

"What's going on with Eti and her birds?"

She sighed heavily and replied to the white-haired girl.

"I should tell you to ask Eti, but you'd probably find out it's because of a terrible avian conspiracy that permeates all social classes and spreads throughout the galaxy. I will tell you everything, although it is not a happy story. You see, here on Atrax, most of us live in a large chasm because of the winds that can strip flesh from bones. There were no native birds on the planet, but some genius brought crows and seagulls there, and

they multiplied terribly in the chasm. Even among the criminals, there was a saying that "partying with the birds" means lying somewhere dead and being gnawed by birds. Our father lived in a great black tower, on top of which great black crows nested. When one of his works did not meet his expectations, he broke its neck and threw it to the birds. Eti… She told you that our father created her, right?" she looked at Rosie, who slowly nodded and then continued. – You see, she was very valuable. It took a lot of resources to create it. She was always very disobedient, it was the intended effect... He came up with an idea, cruel and terrible. "Let me tell you," she looked at the girl.

Rosie stared at her and after a moment she cautiously nodded.

As soon as she was thrown onto the stone top of the tower, she heard cawing. She turned onto her back and saw black birds all around, staring at her with hungry eyes.

"I don't feed them normal meat. I don't want to them feel full. They usually get clones that died during creation, but also those from my creations that did not live up to expectations and are disobedient." came the bass, metallic voice of Jantar, who aroused fear in his children, but also fury in her. "As you can see, they are hungry. Think about your actions as you wait here to be forgiven. – Then the heavy steps of the Creator's metal limbs rang out.

She looked around in panic. She was left alone. The birds stared at her with hungry eyes. She tried to free herself and cut the bonds with her claws, they were so sharp. She could cut metal with them, she could tear those birds apart with no problem. But the bonds were tight and she was unable to break free.

"You can't do that! I will kill you! Hisss! I will kill you!" She screamed and hissed at the black figures surrounding her.

The next day she was found crouched in the middle of the tower. She was clenching her teeth on the crow's carcass. As soon as

one of Jantar's employees approached her, she opened her eyes and hissed.

“Don't come closer! I'll kill you! Hisss”

-

“The punishment made her even more disobedient... More Eti...” she finished the story and looked at Rosie, who was staring at her dumbfounded.

- It's... It's terrible! – she finally said in sign language. – How could your father do such terrible things?

She smiled at the not-quite-intern anymore.

“Be glad you didn't meet one of my sisters. Fortunately, that crazy bitch been dead for years.”

The Valley of the Lost was half the size of the capital of Saltmarsh, but it felt like a much livelier, if more dangerous, place. The buildings were cramped and one could get the impression that the city had recently expanded... Many buildings on the outskirts were quite new, built of prefabricated elements, corrugated iron, and even animal fur, skins and bones. There were various vehicles everywhere, most of them either converted Horde machines, both galactic and local, or homemade works. According to Eti, it all looked like Akiton , and yet completely different. As if someone had pumped all the despair and sense of the approaching doom out of Akiton and infused it with hope and steely determination. She didn't like it at all.

“Okay, we won't go any further... Otherwise we would have to run over other vehicles.” said Bina as she unbuckled her seat belt.

“I don't see a problem with it.” said Crushey in an encouraging voice.

“But their owners will see it.” she said and went outside. Eti privately believed that a large part of these machines deserved to be run over by Crushey, in fact it should have been an honor for them, but she did not want to argue with Bina . She had some plans... She wanted to find out something. She couldn't draw attention to herself of their captain, otherwise he would tell them to stay in Crushey, and then he wouldn't know the Truth.

When they were outside, Bina threw them a map and said.

“Okay, for your young legs, the Bone Haven should be about an hour of walk from here. Don't bother anyone, Eti, it's best not to show up at all. And watch over both of them... for the sake of the dark and righteous gods, do not forget to hydrate yourselves.”

Itel was a good mommy's girl again, and Sparkle Hand looked at her sympathetically. Bina must have told her some sob story and now she saw her as some pathetic, contemptible creature.

“It's quite a cold desert, even the sun doesn't shine.” she said, trying to refrain from commenting on "Don't show up."

“It's probably because of the lack of sun. I think Vampires will like this planet...” Alatar said,

“But these moons make it feel weird to be a werewolf here.” added Lilka.

“It was a fascinating exchange... hit the road.” he shouted and, turning on the cloaking field, they moved deeper into the Red Sands.

“If it weren't for the neon sign, this place would look ominous.” Rosie said as she handed the binoculars back to Itel.

“I would also noticed some laundry. The sight of someone's pants takes away a lot of the scariness. But you're right, it looks definitely more serious than Red Water.” added the Elf. She had

the impression that her green-haired friend had been acting decidedly more polite towards her lately. She turned to Eti, who was scratching the sand with the tip of her shoe. It was probably because of the cat girl that the solarian was nicer to her. Eti had been strangely excited since they landed on Etheria. She understood it a little, because there was something charmed about the atmosphere of this planet. As if a great power penetrated her body with every breath... But it seemed to affect Eti differently, although according to the scout, sometimes she simply felt different...

“I already understand!” Eti called out unexpectedly and Itel also turned towards her.

“What do you understand?” Itel frowned.

“Why did we come here! I saw your cunning plan.” Eti shouted happily.

“What plan?” Itel seemed irritated.

“It's about the sand. You see, Akiton definitely needs more red sand, because it's called Red, after all. its definitely missing there.”

“What are you talking about! – exclaimed the elf, irritated.

“ Excuse me Itel, but I can't think of any other reason why we would leave the fucking desert of Akiton only to first end up in fucking Saltmarsh and then end up in the fucking Crimson Wastes or whatever that stupid place is called.” Eti spread her arms and gesticulated violently, and judging by the expression on her face, she probably raised her voice.

“Calm down! You were supposed to behave!” he elf drawled, and Rosie felt more and more confused. She wasn't used to seeing people arguing, especially her friends.

“I am behaving. Anyhow, but I behave.” she said and pulled her hood over her head and ran towards the Bone Haven.

“Damn. – Iteli said and together they followed the feline girl. Eti didn't slow down until she was inside the ominous structure, and they were with her.

The interior was… what you would expect. It was surprisingly spacious and the air was quite fresh. It was full of menacing-looking people who glared at them as soon as they entered. They belonged to many species, usually covered with scales or fur. They were also armed and definitely didn't seem like very nice people. Still, she waved at them with a friendly smile. Eti looked around and dramatically grabbed her head.

“Well, now we found something that wasn't on Akiton . A den full of thugs!” the scout exclaimed.

“What the hell do you want, Eti? What's wrong with this place being similar to Akiton ? Besides, you quite liked Akiton." the Solarian said , gesturing wildly.

“But it's a fake Akiton ! They don't even have decent weapons here.” She walked up to a creature that looked like a Vesk, only slightly more slender… or maybe just a slender Vesk… and pulled out what looked like an electric baton from his belt. “See how pity this thing is?”

“Hey, leave it!” he exclaimed, standing up. He towered over both girls and was now glaring at them, but Eti put the baton to his chest and turned it on. Discharges spread throughout the reptile's body. He let out a strangled scream that made Rosie jump in fear and he fell to the floor.

“Because it's a more civilized place than Akiton . Where the cat eats the dog. – Itel said and grabbed the baton from Eti's hands.

“Is that a allusion?” the feline asked, and at that time the lizard started to get up and said. “I'll show you as soon as I get up.”

“Don't look for subtext everywhere. And apart from that, it's a really good weapon.” she put the baton at the lizard and electrocuted it again. “You know, I have the impression that

you've been feeling bad lately and you want to spoil mood for everyone around you! – exclaimed the Elf, giving the baton back to Eti.

“I don't feel bad Itel. I had a bad life.” said the cat girl.

“You'll have a bad day, you'll have it as soon as I get up.” Said the lizard and then both girls looked at him and screamed at the same time.

:SILENCE!” Eti electrocuted him again. Then the friends looked at each other for a moment, until Eti finally looked down and said.

“Okay, I'll go sit quietly at the bar and you ask the locals.”

“Just don't buy any alcohol or anything like that, okay?” Itel said and Eti nodded and both girls left and Rossie went to the lizard and helped him up and then she said.

“Are you OK?”

The wiry Vesk shook his head.

“No, during the war I was hit much worse sometimes. Just drink some decent moonshine from the tech department and I'll be good as new.” he said and ordered a drink from a horned waitress.

“It's funny, Miss Daisy, my friend, also likes moonshine from the tech department, but she... we're all not from Etheri, except maybe Emili.”

The lizard took a sip of the foul-smelling liquid and said.

“Then she has no idea. Thanks to the moonshiner in the tech department, the entire Fright Zone was able to function. Hordak might have banned alcohol, but even Shadow Weaver had enough sense in her head to know that without it everything would fall apart. Therefore, it did not enforce this ban.

She felt a sudden twinge of anxiety.

“Who is Shadow Weaver?” she asked, full of bad feelings.

“Or rather, who she was. At least everyone believes she's gone. This was Hordak's right-hand woman, second-in-command. She was a powerful sorceress, the ruler of shadows. She once apparently botched a spell and turned into a monster with a scarred face, so she had to wear a mask. I have never seen a more horrible person. Well, maybe except for Horde Prime, but he was in a separate category.”

She felt the hairs on the back of her neck stand on end. Miss Daisy was nice and good to them. She saved them there in the monastery and also took care of Lady Cala , who was so wonderful... and apparently her ancestors came from Etheri... No, it's just a coincidence. It's just that many mystics who used dark magic had scars because it was an occupational disease... and they liked strong moonshine. To get rid of such terrible thoughts, she asked the lizard.

“You see, we are looking for such... a treasure... Very valuable. Made by the, uh... First Ones.”

The lizard looked at her, then burst out laughing.

“All of Etheria is one great treasure. And to find something smaller, all you have to do is start digging. You can be sure that you will get something. Although now Etheri's greatest treasure is She-Ra...”

She nodded, smiling broadly.

“Yes, we know her... I mean Adora. She is very nice and likes crunchy food. We met her on Icarus...”

The wiry Vesk looked at her for a long moment, then said.

“It doesn't look like you're lying... Well... If you're looking for something really valuable, go to Beast Island. Apparently it was a

Junkyard or something, and Entrapta is there with old bad Hordak. She also liked to collect old First Ones scrap and was said to have received a lot of First Ones treasures. You can also try to go to Dryll, to Castle Crypto, Entrapta's former castle, but Lonnie took it for her People's Rebellion and I don't know if she will want to talk to you. There's also Brightmoon , and if it's true that you met Adora , maybe you'd better go there. But you better watch out for the Grand Marshal. If your friends behave like that there, it may end badly. The one in the coat reminds me a lot of... What the fuck is that?" the lizard stood up abruptly and looked towards the bar where Eti was sitting. She took off her mask and hood. She held her braid and touched the tip of it to the palm of her hand, flexing nervously. The voices slowly quieted down and more and more glances were directed towards the feline girl. Rosie knew something was happening right before her eyes, although she wasn't sure what. Itel was sitting against the wall and seeing how the bar patrons were behaving... And Eti, she summoned a blade. They approached her, and the scout then turned to Rosie.

"You know, I remembered that time on Icarus you asked me why I always hide my face and now I thought that maybe I would reveal myself here, because no one would recognize me... After all, this planet was cut off from the rest of the Galaxy for a thousand years, so no one would recognize me. And look how much no one pays attention to me. Absolutely no one." the cat girl snorted and ran her fingers across the counter. She touched her fingers to the scar on it. It looked like claw marks, similar to those on Emily's...

"You know what, Eti, maybe we'll go away... you'll cool down..." Itel started, but Eti interrupted her

"Shhh" and turned towards the snake person, who was cowering under her gaze. She smiled, which was a very disturbing sight, and moved closer to them.

"Hey, creep. Do you like me so much that you look at me... or do I remind you of someone?" she asked, wrapping her metal arm

tightly around him. The two gnoles stood up and looked at her menacingly.

“We don't know who you are, but we remember when Catra came here and started ruling. And then she gave us back to the Horde. We don't want you here.”Hor

“Catra…” Eti said, almost tenderly. “Thanks boys and girls and other persons.” she pulled a grenade from her belt and threw it. Itel pulled Rossie to the ground. Everything was covered with smoke and the elf dragged her to the exit. There were screams and shouts everywhere. Someone tried to stop her, but she broke his jaw with a punch. They ran outside, followed by Eti dragging the snake person. The cat girl shot blindly from her hip several times and the building began to burn. They ran like that for a few minutes until they found themselves behind a dune. Then Eti stopped and knelt by the snake person, then pulled out the knife attached to her forearm and held it to the captive's throat.

“Who is Catra!” she growled, and the snake person squealed in fear.

“Well, Grand Marshal Catra... She- Ra's fiancée and Hordak's former seccond in command ... She also ruled the Wastes for a while... She's just like you...”

Eti growled and hit her captive with her metal hand fir, then a second time. Drops of blood fell onto the sand, barely visible against its crimson. When Eti was about to deliver a third blow, much stronger than the previous ones, she grabbed her hand. The cat girl turned towards her, a look of pure fury on her face. For a moment, Rosie was afraid that Eti would lunge at her, but suddenly all the fury escaped the feline scout, as if someone had popped a balloon, and she looked down, as if she were ashamed of what she had done... or was about to do... Then she untied the snake-like captive, who immediately ran away and she said in a surprisingly calm, even shy voice.

“I think I did something very stupid... We'd better go back to the ship and tell the others.” she put a dust mask on her face, put a hood over her head and moved forward. She and Itel watched her for a moment until the Elf spoke.

“You know, it's good that you're with us.”

She looked at it surprised.

“I thought I was irritating you.” she said in sign language, and Itel smiled bitterly.

“Because you're irritating. But you're doing a good job on Eti... I wouldn't have stopped her, and she would have suffered later.” she said and followed the shooter, leaving Rosie alone in the scarlet sands.

Enemies we know

Chapter Summary

> And I admit my mistake. I forgot that Scorpia understood what Emily was saying... So Emily forgot about Shadow Weaver.

As soon as they landed and left the ship, she heard a sound. It was painfully irritating, seeping into her bones, into the core of her dark, twisted soul. She shuddered, she had already forgotten how much this place scared her. She had only been here once with Hordak and barely escaped with their lives. That's why over the years they have sent countless unfortunates here under the guise of a research mission... it was a way to circumvent Hordak's conditioning against issuing death sentences. They all died terrible deaths, much worse than she could have imagined. Only Mikah survived, by a miraculous and terrible twist of fate, having lost the love of his life. It was another crime that weighed heavily on her conscience. But not only hers, as she could see. A narrow strip of coastline has been cleared of this strange metal flora. From what she had heard, something similar was covering the First Ones cities on Abbalon ... It explained so much and at the same time led to more questions. In front of them stood a clumsy castle, as if made of scrap metal and random devices. According to Wrongdak, it was Entrapta's new castle . It was called Castle Junk , and she had to admit that it was an extremely apt name. Hordak's kinder brother dropped his ears as soon as they reached the shore. But as soon as he saw the building on the island, he smiled broadly.

“My brother and Entrapta live there.” he said with delight in his voice.

“We'll be happy to meet him. Go ahead and announce us, and we'll take a look around the island at that time.” she said in a

gentle voice.

“Be careful.” said Mr. Ilemshaw in a metallic voice through one of his drones. “I cannot scan the interior, but I detect various disturbances coming from inside and a signal that is probably the product of extremely advanced technology. Additionally, I sense the presence of many forms of life, both organic and non-organic. And considering the name of this place, they are probably very dangerous.”

“It's a bit like someone combined Castroval with Abbalon . Wow, a two-in-one trip.” Ireanis exclaimed, looking around curiously. She smiled happily like a child at a festival. The instinct of self-preservation was not her strong suit...

Said the woman who sold her soul to the eldritch evil and is now going to make arrangements with the person who has already sentenced her to death once.

“Don't worry, Mr. Ilemshaw, we are really resourceful women.” she said, smiling cheerfully, although honestly she preferred not to stay here long. Although she was stronger now than then, and her body was much healthier, but from what she overheard when Adora and the others talked about this place, she had never experienced the worst, and the confirmation of their story was the vibrating sound that caused she felt as if someone was drilling a hole in her soul. Plus she wanted to drink. However, she couldn't afford to be so weak before meeting Hordak

They moved away from the landing zone, and Wrongdak moved forward, eager to meet his brother. Emily stayed back and watched her triumphantly with one eye, clearly believing that her creator would defeat her. *Unfortunately, little one, you are late. Now I'm the one dealing the cards.* Then the bot or Droid as they call them in the galaxy left and they were left alone.

“So again... You were born into this world and worked for this guy we're going to visit now, right?” Ireanis asked. She nodded. Earlier on the ship, she had revealed some of the truth about herself to

the elf, without revealing who she served or saying much about what she had done when she was second-in-command. It was a bit of a risk, but she figured she could either let her in on some of the truth or get rid of it. In the past, she sometimes organized tragic accidents among her competitors, but in this case it would be too suspicious, and after all... She was trying to be someone better... Perhaps the Elf's help would come in handy, she tried very hard to convince her to do so.

Strangely, Ireanis took her news surprisingly well. She wondered if the sorcerer understood what she was saying. Due to alcohol abuse, Ireanis was not one of the brightest stars in the sky, euphemistically speaking.

“To put it very simply, you're right. – confirmed the sorceress's question. She only said "Aha" and did not pursue the topic further.

“It really doesn't surprise you that you're traveling with a woman who comes from a planet that has been cut off from the rest of the galaxy for thousands of years and happens to be same place where we're going”

Ireanis shrugged.

“Stuff like this happens all the time. For example, I cast a spell incorrectly and from the Mwangi jungle I was transported to the future and to a planet attacked by big bugs.”

She looked at the elf, trying to see through her, but all she saw was a broad, cheerful smile.

“Are you serious, you really believe in this nonsense.” she said, incredulously.

“I believe because it's true, even if I imagined it all. You know, some peoplw say life is a dream.” Ireanis explained in a cheerful tone. She looked at her and laughed darkly.

“Maybe you're right... Although sometimes it can be a nightmare.”

“Child! Could you please stop behaving in such a ridiculous and insubordinate way!” he said in a commanding tone, but the Child pushed his hands and head away with they prehensile hair. They were belligerent after him and independently after Entrapta . A perfect combination of genes. He loved them as much as he never thought it is possible... But now he had to wear them after they got covered in oil He sighed and said in a pleading tone, "Dad is asking, let him change your clothes!"

The Child calmed down a bit, so he was able to get dressed, although he was still out of breath. Then he gave him an old broken clock that was supposedly a gift from the ruler of Eridani or something, but of course Catra broke it. They have so many of them. The child liked to tinker with them and last year she made a catcher with which she could remove the balls when they fell behind the furniture. He couldn't say from whom it inherited such practical sense He sighed and sat down in the chair, then sighed heavily. Being a parent could be extremely exhausting...

As he sat and rested, watching the child work intently on the remains of the clock, he felt an overwhelming longing for Entrapta again . At the same time, he was glad that she could be among her friends for a while, even if it meant being with Catra. He exiled himself to the place where he had sent so many, but he didn't expect that Entrapta would go with him ... that they would get married and have a baby together... He was happy, and that made him feel terrible. He knew that this exile was much harder for his wife than for him...

Recently, a ship landed on the landing pad. That was another reason he wished Entrapta was here. She always took better care of guests. He could only hope that the visitors would fly away at the sight of a castle or an island. But then a voice came from the speaker.

“Brother! I came back!

It was Wrong Hordak, his younger brother with an absurd name. He left them a few years ago, wanting to explore the galaxy and collect data for Entrapta ... Since then, there has been no news from him, apart from the fact that he apparently flew away with some furry creatures, he suspected that something terrible had happened to him, although he did not share his fears with Entrapta . He himself encouraged him to go on this expedition. He wanted some privacy with his partner, and his younger brother could be very intense. Now he understood that he had been driven by childish selfishness and that if anything bad had happened to Wrong Hordak, he was responsible for this. But now he's back, so everything will be fine.

“Come in, brother.” he smiled, feeling a surge of relief. “I am glad you came back.” he said and gave the command to open the outer door. - You're about to meet Uncle Wrong ... Hordak - he said to the Child, realizing that he would have to explain a lot to him when he got older.

He waited for his brother for a few minutes, obviously he had to find his way in the castle, which had grown during his absence. He was waiting for him in the living room, the place where Entrapta kept the things she worked on when she received guests... When he saw Wrong Hordaka, his eyes widened. He was... colorful, weird and absurd. He even dyed his hair rainbow. He walked up to him and hugged him tightly.

“I'm so happy to see you after all these years. I have so much to tell you.” he exclaimed. At first he stiffened, but then he responded with an equally strong hug

“I'm glad to see you too. I need to introduce someone.” he smiled and moved away from him and pointed to the Child. “This is the Child, brother. Child this is my brother Wrong …”

“Wrongdak” his brother interrupted “Now everyone calls me that.” And he kneel down next to the child, looking at him with

fascination. The child was also watching him with his eyes open. Emily stood next to her, looking at the baby.

“Hello... I think I'm your uncle.” said his brother gently, and then the Child yelled “Wrongdak. Uncle Wrongdak!” and they climbed onto his back and wrapped they hair around his neck. Wrongdak laughed, but Emily started talking to him. However, he didn't have time to understand what exactly she wanted to tell him, but then his brother spoke.

“I also need to introduce someone to you. I have come here with many extraordinary people, but most of them are not with me now... But I have brought two great Sorceresses. Misses Daisy and Ireanis Toromech Called the Silver Flame.

He sighed. He was in no mood for guests, even less for sorcerers. But if he had to…

“Good Morning, Lord Hordak.” came a mocking voice. He knew him very well. For decades, he had accompanied him in his war against the people of Etheri... His brother... Wrongdak frowned, obviously seeing what emotions he was feeling now.

“Take the Child.” he said sharply.

“But brother... What happened?” the younger clone asked, but was interrupted by a loud scream

“Do it!”

Wrongdak cringed, but obediently grabbed the little one who was about to run to the new arrivals and dragged them away.

“Do as your Brother wants, Mr. Wrongdak” Shadow Weaver said in that falsely polite voice she liked to use when she wanted something.

He turned around, standing between the child and his brother, and the dark sorceress. When he looked at her, he blinked in surprise. Shadow Weaver wore no mask, and her face was

unscarred. He had seen her without her mask several times and it was never a pleasant sight. Now she looked completely normal for... Saihe. That was the name of her species, if he wasn't mistaken. She had green eyes and dark green hair and gray skin. She looked quite nice, he noted anxiously. Next to her stood a black woman of the same species. She had long silver hair and a green strapless robe. She smiled happily at him and waved her hand. Wrongdak took the Child in his arms and left with Emily.

“You too, my dear, could you leave us?” Shadow Weaver turned to the other woman, who inhaled sharply.

“Ah yes, after all these years you want to spend some time alone.” She said in a conspiratorial tone.

His former right hand looked at the silver-haired woman in surprise.

“What are you insinuating, Ireanis?” she exclaimed indignantly.

“You know, you were a couple for so many years and then you were separated... Now you'll probably want to make up for time.” Ireanis replied and winked knowingly.

“WE ARE NOT A COUPLE!” they shouted at the same time and Saihe said.

“Okay, of course... and she went out in the opposite direction as his brother, whistling cheerfully. When they were alone, he smiled. He was a trained warrior, his body was functional again, and he was wearing powerful power armor. It wasn't a combat model, but it should be enough. In one bound he was right next to her and slammed his metal hand against the wall.

“Shadow Weaver... I should have known that someone like you couldn't act like any proper being and stay dead.”

The dark sorceress smiled. She didn't look scared.

“The bone sages of Eox would find your words offensive and politically incorrect.”

“What? What are you talking about?” he asked, confused, and his former right hand sighed heavily.

“Exactly, Lord Hordak. For years you considered the people of Etheri ignorant, without even understanding the extent of your own ignorance.”

He growled, feeling that he was losing ground under his feet.

“Give me one reason to spare you. No one would blame me if I killed you.”

“But you didn't.” she looked at him contemptuously. “And that's a good thing, because you would be harming your family”

“You dare threaten my loved ones in my house!” he shouted at her, but she didn't even move. She used to be afraid of him, even when she was at the height of her power. Now she looked tired… even resigned.

“I'm not threatening you, I'm just warning you, and believe me, it's not me you should be afraid of.”

The tone of her voice made him step back.

“What do you want from me?” he asked in a slightly calmer tone, but he was still ready to kill her at the slightest provocation.

“I thought you were one of the few people on Etheria who would listen to me, and as you can see, I was not wrong.” the smile disappeared from her face. “Your Brother's actions and especially his fall did not go unnoticed. The greatest powers of the galaxy sent a fleet here to explore the Ravaged Zone, as Horde Prime's empire is called, and especially a certain planet that had recently appeared in the Galaxy. It is commanded by Lord Admiral Antares , a mercenary of galactic fame, widely regarded as a hero, but whose heart is as black as your brother's.

He snorted contemptuously.

“No one on Etheria will be afraid of someone who is willing to sell himself for a few coins.”

Shadow Weaver laughed, clearly amused.

“When I ruled the Horde on your behalf, I often used those who fought for money. From what I know, Catra did the same.” she thought for a moment.

“She's so similar to you.” he said, and his former right-hand man glared at him.

“Skip these personal attacks. Lord Admiral Antares is not just any thug who will stab anyone you point at him. He was once the ruler of the planet Tarak , before he was expelled from there. He then faced the Swarm for thirty years and survived.” she said with absolute seriousness, and the way she spoke about the Lord Admiral made him feel like he was losing his self-confidence

“Who is the Swarm?” he asked, confused.

“Or rather, what the Swarm is. It is a Hunger that cannot be satiated. Thousands of thousands of maws ready to devour everything that stands in its path. This is the greatest plague of the Galaxy, an enemy that makes the power of the Galactic Horde pale in comparison. And this man had been fighting him for decades, not only ensuring his survival, but winning victories while we were stuck in our ridiculous war on Etheria.”

It pained him to call his attempt to conquer Etheri ridiculous, but he couldn't deny its validity, which caused him even more pain.

“If he is such a great commander and a great Hero, why are you so afraid of him? Someone like that will be useful to the Queen when she fights against my silly brothers.”

Then Shadow Weaver laughed, but not in the triumphant or mocking way he had heard from her so often, that had always

irritated him so much, but in a way that was completely devoid of joy, but full of pure desperation. She pressed something on the back of her neck and her face blurred, and then he saw her as he remembered... But she had changed. There was no anger or pain in her face that always pushed her to the worst horrors. *What happened to her over the years?*

"Lord Admiral Antares is a monster that I helped bring here through my ignorance." she said quietly. "He waged a brutal civil war on his home world and dropped nuclear warheads on his own planet as he left it." she looked into his eyes and he saw a tear roll down her cheek. Then he felt real fear.

"What can I do? I have no power on Etheria I was lucky to be allowed to exile here. Many want my head, both those who fought for me and those I wronged. For not reporting that you were back, I could have lost what little freedom I had left." he said completely honestly. He felt the most powerless and useless he had felt in five years... since he had met Entrapta .

Shadow Weaver did something she had never done in twenty-five years of knowing her, she put her hand on his shoulder and said.

"You have experience. You wagged war for Thirty Years, and there is no more experienced commander on the planet. However, you have something, determination, something to fight for. I saw Adora, Glimmer and the others fight with nothing else, and I know that was often enough for them. You have a family you need to protect. But also something else. We were both given a second chance to make up for our mistakes, to atone for the wrong we had done. Prove to everyone that you have changed, that you have become a better person. – she moved away from him, but without taking her eyes off him, he considered her words and slowly nodded.

"Agreement. I will help you, but if you cheat on me... " he threatened her, but she just smiled sadly.

“If I fail, beings old and powerful beyond imagination will claim my vile soul and give me a punishment that will make whatever Horde Prime did to you feel like a friendly nudge. Or maybe they will let me live, knowing what a pathetic and contemptible creature I am. I'll try to contact you... It would be nice if you managed to get to the Victory Day party.”

“I'll try, but I don't promise anything.” he said carefully, and the dark Sorceress went to the exit, but took a step forward. He wanted to confess... To confess the terrible sin he had committed five years ago, which no one knew about except him and that poor unfortunate creature, if it survived, but he had no courage. Instead he stated.

“You've changed, Shadow Weaver.”

She stopped and replied.

“Death changes mortals...” she turned and asked again. “How is Catra? Are she and Adora happy?”

He smiled sourly.

“Our relationship is not very good... But she seems happy, but she doesn't remember you very fondly.”

She nodded slowly.

“I don't deserve anything else.”

After Shadow Weaver left, he moved into the next room. The Child was drawing something on Emily, and his little brother was struggling to keep from bursting into tears. He stopped as soon as he saw him, he just started crying

“I am really sorry. I didn't know it was her, I never talked to her. Emily guessed, but she didn't know what to do, she was afraid that if the truth came out, she would do something to me and

other crew members... And then she forgot. She was so nice to everyone, especially Rosie and Eti. Eti is...” his voice broke down. He sighed, he came here with the intention of yelling at his brother for endangering his family, but he realized it was pointless. Instead, he helped him up and gave him a big hug.

“She can be extremely nice when she knows she can get something out of it. She cheated in front of you.” he sighed heavily, because he was about to ask Wrongdak for something that could turn out to be very painful for him. He moved away from his brother and spoke seriously.

“You have to do something for me. For me and Entrapta” he sighed again, because he was aware that she was asking a lot from him. – Return to the ship and keep an eye on Shadow Weaver.

Wrongdak blinked several times as if he didn't understand what he was saying, he wasn't sure what exactly he wanted from him.

"But… we have to inform the others, warn them about her…" his brother protested, and he sighed heavily in response.

“It's not that simple. What she told me... we need her... at least for now. I know her well... Better than anyone else on Etheria... And I know what to expect from her. If what she says is true, then... we have bigger problems than a lying sorceress.” he said, feeling chills spreading through his body. “I don't know how she managed to fool everyone so well... But she's known Catra and Adora forever. She exploited the weakness she had instilled in them, much like Horde Prime did to us. “Beware. She once had great power, and now... But her most dangerous weapon is her mind, warped and twisted. You can't trust a word that comes out of her mouth.”

“If she is so dangerous, we need to inform others even more.” Wrongdak exclaimed, and his words sounded reasonable, but… he knew that she was definitely telling the truth about this Lord Admiral.

“Sometimes, brother, the enemies we know are better.”

Legend of the Crimson Wastes

Bina really liked this place. They saw thugs and tricksters armed to the teeth everywhere. She saw also all kinds of goods on the stalls, and absolutely no one thought about their legality and origin. Most of it was junk, but she spotted some interesting things here... For example, these batons, supposedly from the Horde, designed by Hordak himself ... Isn't it Wrongdak 's brother or something... Damn, looking at the white-skinned alien, she didn't expect that other clones were so smart... But it was the same in her family. Some of her sisters, especially the M-nations, were devilishly intelligent, and others, like a certain Ka who, luckily, actually partied with the birds, were completely fucked up.

However, they didn't find much that resembled the Technology of the First Ones. Although, truth be told, she wasn't sure what exactly they should be looking for. Perhaps they shouldn't split up with Arkan-Tar and the rest of Cala's team just yet. But it was too late for that now. Still, they found some interesting items. They were usually cracked crystals covered with inscriptions resembling star constellations. Even if they had no practical use, they could sell them to any collector on Absalom for a handsome sum. And they weren't even expensive... Well, maybe they would have been if they paid for them in coins, but luckily they had a lot of old electronics, which were very valuable on such an underdeveloped planet. The problem was Alatar…

"NO! This may come in handy!" Dragonkin shouted, snatching some gadget from her hands.

"You don't use it anyway... You know what you collect, it's like..." she said, but he interrupted her indignantly.

"Say it! Do you mean like a DRAGON!"

“LIKE A NERD. DAMN NERD!” she shouted at him, and the seller, a cat-person more gaunt and smaller than the usual Pahtra, laughed.

“You will find dragons in fairy tales, nowhere else.” he said, clearly amused.

“Really…?” she looked at Alatar, who was watching at her pleadingly. “I've seen several dragons in my life, by my own eyes, and I have the impression that you wouldn't recognize him even if he stood right in front of your eyes.” she said, and the seller snorted.

“I saw some in drawings, they were huge and had a big mouth full of sharp teeth. Apparently they devoured everything that stood in their way.” he said, looking a little more closely at the young technomancer, who did not notice it and responded with sincere indignation.

“This is a disgusting specist stereotype!”

“You know, Alatar, you can eat a lot too.” said Lilka, stroking Toshi, who was sucking the battery. He has to remind her not to overfeed the fox because then he starts kicking with electricity when someone touches him.

Dragonkin was about to start arguing, but she interrupted him.

“Back to business.” she pointed to a large fragment of a mosaic depicting two women, one damn tall and a child between them. “It's nice, but I'm looking for something... bigger and more usable, if you know what I mean.” she said, and the skinny cat frowned.

“Hmm, I would ask Grox. She had a lot of interesting equipment, she even had a mechanical hand, although not such wonders as this one.” he pointed at Alatar. “He she only moved out after Huntara banished her after she sided with the Horde. Now he's at Tung's Lashor and his Aspis gang.” the cat scratched behind the ear. “There is also Goldeneyes , but he is quite strange... He is

more of a collector and researcher than a typical trader, but he is honest, and he doesn't get along with Aspies”

“Aspies?” she said and exchanged knowing glances with Alatar and Lilka. “So this plague got even here?”

“Yes, the Tung Lashor gang, supposedly the most powerful gang in the Wastes, or the second most powerful gang in the Wastes... or the second most powerful. Depends on who you ask. Tung once lost power to Catra, but after the invasion many came back to him for protection, especially when Huntara was chipped. Now Tung Lashor claims to be allied with the People's Rebellion, but Lonnie has not confirmed this.”

"Catra you say..." she said, smiling nervously. She chose this place to start exploring this planet because she expected that not many people here knew Adora's fiancée and she probably miscalculated. She looked towards where she left Crusher parked. Maybe she should turn back to the transporter and go get Eti. The girl was nervous when people stared at her, and if they were so alike, the locals they won't be able to take their eyes off her

. On the other hand, Eti did not like to reveal her face in public, she did not do it even in front of Adora, whom she immediately liked. Maybe he won't do it here either. Besides, there were her orders, there was a slight chance that she wouldn't ignore them this time.

“Kitira sounds a bit like a name for someone with cat ears like Eti.” said Lilka.

“The last time Wrongdak addressed her like that, she pissed him off so much that he immediately bent in half.”

“Eti?” asked the cat.

“Our friend. He looks like a you Mr Cat, but has a girl face and a metal hand made by Adora's kin. And such nice eyes, a gold with blue dots...

“Yeah? “the feline asked in a concerned voice. He hasn't met Eti yet, but he's already scared.

“So why don't you tell us where this Goldeneyes lives and we'll stop bothering you?” she asked, trying to sound as neutral as possible. She wanted to change the subject with Eti and start talking about the reason why they came to this planet.

The cat rubbed his chin and replied.

“He lives at the end of the valley, you have to take the side road near the yellow stones, but be careful. You can get visions from the fumes there. It happens that you can come across various suspicious individuals looking for a high...”

“Sound familiar. Thanks for news” she said and set off with Lilka and Alatar, not seeing the seller enter the booth where he lived and turn on the walkie-talkie .

“Hey Tung. I have a tip... there are some interesting people from other worl...”

Huntara stretched, feeling all her bones touch. She wondered if she was getting too old for all this. She was forty-five years old. It was an advanced age for her people, the sentinels. Okay, she was exaggerating, but she would be expected to attend council of elders and such. She wasn't sure what they actually did as adults. She was ten years old when Hordak arrived and her clan sided with the Scorpion King against their rightful ruler, and they paid a terrible price for this. She was the last member of her clan. She wondered if she should adopt in a kid or make it in a modern way with some nice girl to pass on the traditions of her people... but she remembered very little of them by herself. She also didn't learn many secrets reserved for older warriors and bone gnawers. And most importantly, she had neither a suitable partner nor time to take care of the kid. She covered the two Saihe girls with a blanket, with whom she spent the night. They were sweet and

charming, but it was just a one night relationship, nothing that would provide a peaceful home.

She went outside and looked at the sky. During the day, you couldn't see how much the world had changed since Etheria got out of Despondos, although the sky was a slightly different color and sometimes, with the right arrangement of moons, you could see the stars, but at night... The entire sky was dotted with them. For some it was a beautiful sight, for others it was terrifying... The inhabitants of the Crimson Wastes were pragmatic and, depending on their needs, an additional source of light at night could be either a help or a hindrance.

But this was an insignificant change compared to those taking place on the surface of Etheria. The planet suddenly became much smaller. Horde skimmers suddenly became widely available and continued to be manufactured in the Joy Zone, or rather the entire Scorpion country as it was sometimes called. There were other machines, much more advanced. Damn, there were spaceships on Etheria now, when not long ago there was a fight over one thousand-year-old wreck. Now, if someone really wanted to, they could go to another planet. Residents of other worlds also came to Etheria. Here in the Crimson Waste you could mostly find Icarians who mainly sold portable communicators and mechanical prosthetics, but she also knew one who had opened a bar here selling their food, which in her opinion was not very tasty. There were also residents of Bellum wearing gas masks, although they claimed that they came here for holidays. Listening to the stories about their home planet, she could believe it.

But there was something else. It was a sense of impending change, something completely new and unknown that could come to Etheria at literally any moment. Many associated it with the celebration of Victory Day, the Formation of the Galactic Alliance, the invasion of Horde Prime's Successors, or even the return of the First Ones. She didn't care, she just felt tired. There was a limit to the amount of change someone could endure in their life, and she had experienced a lot of them in her life. Hordak's arrival and formation of the Horde, desertion and life in the Crimson

Wastes, joining the alliance, occupation and finally victory. This was too much for an ordinary warrior, and if there was something else waiting for her…

She was eating lizard skewers when she saw a small reptile with red scales, Ishki as the species was called, making its way towards her. They lived in the wastelands in small numbers, always keeping themselves apart from others. This particular one, however, was quite well known in the Valley. His name was Ruki, he worked as a messenger for many traders and other similar people. He was as friendly as he was agile and could not complain about the lack of customers. Recently he even somehow improved his legs so that he could run much faster... Those prosthetic guys from Icarus were really good.

“Boss, Goldeneyes asks you to come to him. He has important news for you regarding what you told him to look for.”

She sighed. Not a moment of peace. She was really getting too old for this.

One of the advantages of traveling with a self-propelled ax like Lilka and, let's be honest, a huge dragonkin, was that absolutely everyone stayed out of their way and didn't bother them even when Toshi was stealing their Batteries. The city reminded her of Atrax, only less depressing and not as dark. Maybe she'll really settle down here if everything goes well. Several men and women where checking her out, and one quite well-built deer-man even winked at her. Well, maybe later she would try to found him and they could spend a few... or more than a few nice moments together...

“They have kebab here!” exclaimed Lilka, beaming with joy. She smiled and bought both of them a meat and a cactus roll. Alatar got a triple portion. It was so spicy that Eti would probably joke that it would soon start breathing fire from both sides.

Finally they reached a place where there was a side path from which the smell of sulfur was coming. It was a bit tighter in here and she told her kids to activate the environmental protection so they wouldn't get poisoned by the fumes coming from inside the earth. They put also a special mask on Toshi, which they bought for him for such moments, although the electric fox wasn't particularly happy. There were few inhabitants here and most of them looked suspicious, or at least tried to look suspicious, but no one bothered them... Until they encountered two short Bugbears lying unconscious near a black pit. One stood up and said to Lilka.

“Get out of here! My brother and I are resting.” His voice was hoarse. He spat yellow sticky phlegm onto Lilka's one of her authentic orcish pink shoes. It was worse than saying to Eti "Pspspsps" The red-haired girl roared and hit him in the stomach with the handle of the axe, and when he bent in half, she hit him on the head with two fists , and when he fell, she kicked him again. His brother tried to get up, but Alatar hit him with the butt of his Rifle.

“Do you see, dear children? Drugs are bad.” he said without even slowing down.

“And violence is always the best solution.: added Lilka. When Alatar walked over one of the scarecrows , it groaned loudly.

“It uually sounds different Lilka, but in this case it fits perfectly.”

They walked for some time through this tangled maze of tunnels, turning back several times, until they finally reached a not very deep hole, at the bottom of which was a large building that looked like a workshop next to something resembling a Geothermal Power Plant. It looked quite professional. Now she could tell the kids to take off the environmental protection, although they left the mask on Toshi so he wouldn't steal the batteries. They went downstairs and she whistled a tune she had known since she was born. It was irritating and disturbing, getting on the nerves of everyone who heard it, but their father Jantar adored it. All his creations knew that song, even Eti... Did she know her too?

Downstairs, a huge scorpion man, the same species as Scorpia, was waiting by the door. She was glad that Lilka had met the other woman earlier, so they had now avoided the traditional Lilka's rage. Instead, Lilka waved at him and smiled happily at him.

"Hello, are you a friend of Mrs. Scorpia?" she asked with innocent curiosity. The scorpion looked at her darkly.

"I wouldn't say so." he replied coldly.

"Can Mr. Goldeneyes have us?" she asked, trying to change the subject. Her kids liked Scorpia , and it wasn't easy to win their sympathy, but she knew that life wasn't that simple. However, before the Scorpion man could respond, a tall figure jumped down from above, the sight of which made Lilka smile happily.

She felt a twinge of worry as she saw the Strag brothers lying there, moaning. This didn't surprise her too much. It wasn't the first time they had been beaten because they were trying to pick a fight with someone stronger than themselves. Only when tolder started talking about pink shoes, she frowned but shrugged. After all, the brothers spent far too much time inhaling underground fumes. She herself wrapped her face with a rag to avoid being poisoned yourself. She only took it off when she reached the Goldeneyes headquarters. He was one of the older inhabitants of the valley. She met him long before she became "Princess of the Crimson Wastes" shortly after she defected from the Horde. They became friends and she gave him protection... Unfortunately, their friendship brought Tung Lashor's wrath upon him … During the occupation, he hid, even when she was chipped. He returned a few years later, although he was still more secretive than before. He often asked her about Adora, She- Ra and, quite oddly, Catra, but he asked her not to tell them about him, and she respected that decision, she owed it to him , even though she knew that sooner or later his existence would come to light. to the ears of

the princesses, because it was no secret. But it was his choice and she had nothing to do with it.

She arrived at his abode, which resembled a combination of workshop, home, shop, and sanctuary. However, she saw that Goldeneyes had guests, so she had to hurry, because once he received someone, he could chat with them for several hours. So she stood at the edge of his pit, took a deep breath, and jumped down, landing on her bent legs. She smiled to herself. She might not be young anymore, but she was still tough. As soon as she looked up, she heard a joyful cry. She saw a red-haired girl with red braids, wearing a poncho that concealed armor. She had some strange tattoos around her neck and a large ax in her hands. She smiled broadly at her and ran up, then started talking to her in a language completely unknown to her, while swinging her ax and dancing. Worst of all, she expected her to understand her. She just hoped that someone would soon explain to her what was going on here. Then she heard another person present, a burgundy-haired woman, quite attractive... who began to speak to her in the same language, or at least a very similar one. She felt panic attacking her. Why did they expect him to understand what they were saying to her.

“She doesn't seem to understand Orcish.” said the third person, a silver-scaled lizard with many implants. He brought to mind the sky firelord of old legends.

“What is an orcish?” she asked, a bit confused

“Orc! You are an orc! I'm an orc! We're both orcs... How can you not know that?” the red-haired woman asked excitedly. She understood less and less about all this.

“It's your species... although I don't think you care about it that much here on Etheria. My name is Bina and this is Alatar and Lilka

Wagardotir. They are both my wards. And then there is Toshi , the silver fox. – said Bina, and a blue fox wearing a gas mask flew out of the redhead's poncho. He flew up to her and started sniffing her, huffed as if in disappointment and went back under the girl's clothes. – I think we're all going to this Goldeneyes , and I guess we'll have to sort this out somehow. – Bina continued

"I'll just ask the boss." said Scorpion, who was her old friend. His name was Snap. Together they left the Horde and lived in the Wastes. He could have returned to his country, but he chose to stay here. He had not forgotten the Usurper King's crimes, and Scorpia was still his granddaughter. The lizard began to stare at the screen on his shoulder. Lilka looked at her with a mixture of pride and compassion, no one had ever looked at her like that before. And Bina started whistling some song, unpleasant and irritating. They seemed as nice as they were disturbing. To break the silence, she decided to introduce herself.

"I am Huntara ... Some call me the Princess of the Scarlet Wastes."

They waved and said hello to her, and then Alatar stated with delight.

"So you are the fourth princess we meet... the fifth if we count Lady Cala." He said and Lilka then added.

"And how do we count Eti, because..." she started, but Bina glared at her and said.

- On Icarus, my kids met Adora , Perfuma and Scorpia and became friends with them. First, of course, Lilka attacked Scorpia because she thought she was a component of the swarm, and then there was this funny story about a certain pirate... But this is probably becoming the norm for us.

"Damn, maybe I should really go on those diplomatic missions sometimes, because some really interesting things are happening

there." She thought and was about to ask for details when the door opened and Snap said they could enter.

The Goldeneyes household was lit only by glowing mushrooms that the host had cultivated, first collecting them in the caves that were plentiful in the Wasteland. Everything was cluttered with his finds and things he had built. There were a number of minor First Ones artifacts here, and some relics from Etheria's history after planet was closed in Despondos . However, they were not intended to be sold, at least not for money. Their owner made his living mainly by selling transmitters, scanners and batteries that he made himself. With the money obtained in this way, he funded expeditions into the wilderness, in which he usually participated.

Many found the sight of Goldeneyes disturbing or even terrifying. It had a roughly humanoid body. His slightly androgynous face had four faceted, golden eyes, which were quite common among animals living on this planet, although she hadn't seen any other intelligent creature that had them. However, a tangle of limbs emerged from his arms and lower torso, making him look like something out of a nightmare. Some of the arms ended with grippers, others with saws or welders... Most of the guests trembled with fear when they saw him for the first time, even she wanted to beat him to death with a club when they first meet, but these three seemed completely unmoved by the host's presence. And it’s not surprise her. Bina looked around the workshop with interest. Lilka devoured cookies that no one else wanted to touch, and Alatar looked at Goldeneyes' limbs .

“I think I have this year's Ovitech catalog somewhere, I saw something similar there, although it probably cost about ten thousand credits, if not more.” said the lizard. Godeneyes looked at him and said in a slow drawl.

“Indeed, I might consider it, although as far as I know, I don't have any loans.” the host looked at the lizard with a bit of curiosity, but then she interrupted him.

“Thank you for your hospitality, but tell me, what do you want from me?” she asked in a tired voice, sensing that this would not end with an ordinary conversation.

"I know where Mara's tomb is," the host said, and Bina looked at him in surprise.

“I heard about her...” she said, and Alatar nodded.

“Yes, this was the previous She-Ra, and the ancestor of Lady Cala’s.” The lizard explained.

“Who is Lady Cala?” she asked, not understanding what they meant.

“Lady Cala Grayskull of Carurystal. An aristocrat who came here with us, along with her companions. She says she's a descendant of this Mara and I have no reason not to believe her. She would probably like to see the place where the founder of her family was buried. Only she's not with us for now...” Bina said in a thoughtful voice, and Goldeneyes looked at her, smiling mysteriously.

“Yes. I sensed well that several beings arrived on Etheria today, who had ties to its past and future.” He took one of those modern satellite maps out of the closet and marked the coordinates on it. With one strong movement, he tore them into several pieces and gave half of them to her and the other to Bina . “Take it and find it together... But remember that many secrets hide pain and sadness.”

“Yes, I know something about it.” Bina said in a thoughtful voice.

She was about to ask the host what he meant, but then a breathless Ruki ran into his place.

“Boss, someone set fire to the Bone Refuge. They say it's Catra, and not Catra simultaneously and she made such a mess that it took a month to clean up.”

Then Bina hid her face in her hands and said.

“I will murder Eti.”

Mirror images

“Well, you probably don't feel comfortable around me. “ she said to Wrongdak, but the clone responded angrily.

“You're bad... Very bad. You hurt Adora, Catra and others.” and pursed his lips. She had never seen him truly angry during these weeks, although she had become accustomed to Hordak's fits of rage. Apparently Shadow Weaver deserved it…

“Yes, I have hurt a lot of people and for base reasons... usually. Know that I did not come back here of my own free will and with no bad intentions.” she explained to Wrongdak in a calm voice, which she usually used to address Adora when she wanted to force her to behave appropriately. To Adora, but not Catra... Usually not to Catra.

Wrongdak lowered his head dejectedly and said in a voice devoid of all hope.

“It's my fault. If I had looked at you more carefully... If I had talked to Emily...” a tear rolled down his cheek.

She smiled darkly.

“I suggested to Emily that if she told you the truth, the consequences would be dire. But even if you warned the expedition members about my true nature, do you think they would believe you? That the teacher of such a wonderful young lady like Lady Cala, coming from the peaceful but provincial Carurystal, could be a monster who waged a bloody war for thirty years on a planet that no one had heard of for thousands of years? No, my dear, no one would believe you, at most they would treat you as someone insane who should be locked in a cabin for his own safety.” she explained to him in a calm, slightly tired voice.

“When Lady Cala learns the truth” he said, trying to sound menacing, but she burst out laughing in a sinister but desperate way.

“Lady Cala knows truths that even my black heart refuses to know.” she said, seeing his confused face, she added. “Young lady is not who she seems. I can't tell you much about the true nature of my... ward, but don't let her know that you know who I am. I couldn't protect you from her wrath, and it would destroy my fragile alliance with Hordak . Besides, unlike your brother, I like you. And don't worry, I know he told you to spy on me. He was always so predictable. Contrary to appearances, this is a good feature of a ruler. Not necessarily of the general.”

When Hordak's younger brother returned to the ship with them, along with his Droid, she knew immediately that he had learned the truth. He looked at her with that judgmental anger that she had seen many times during her short stay in Brightmoon , especially from Adora, and would most likely see again during this mission. Like most things that happened to her in life, she earned it through her actions.

They now stood near the landing site of the flying rocks that took travelers to Mystacor. Around it was the Sorcerer's Valley, where there were several towns that supplied the largest magical college on the planet, or rather the only one. From what she had heard, during the war they were either protected by some of Mystacor's magic or were abandoned. But now they were teeming with life, as was all of Etheria. She was surprised to find that she enjoyed it, even though she spent her entire life trying to put the entire planet in chains.

Eventually they stepped onto a shipping stone that had some students with it. One of them was a lizard... Vesk, who was raised in the Horde judging by his accent, but they only noticed Wrongdak... Although Ireanis waved cheerfully at them. During the flight, she thought about her conversation with Hordak. It went much better than she hopes. She expected she would have to incapacitate him before they could talk. He had changed more

than she thought. And that child. The sight of Hordak caring for his offspring almost made her stunned. She had seen many strange things over the years, but this topped almost everything. The baby was a hybrid of two species... just like Eti and... Catra. Did Entrapta guess the nature of her friend? After all, she herself brought a very similar creature to life. It was only after her own death that she began to think of herself as a mother, even if a very bad one. However, when she saw Entrapta's offspring, she remembered Asindesa's question about whether she could have children. The idea was absolutely ridiculous and absurd, but she would never have even thought about it before.

Hordak agreed to make an agreement with her. However, she managed to convince him mainly because she was honest with him. She exposed herself to him much more than she wanted to, but it clearly turned out to be a good tactic. Unfortunately, he was right. Of all her potential allies, he risked the most, but also had the least to offer her. That's why she came here, hoping to attract someone much more influential. But this will be more difficult.

Mystacor had changed since she abandoned it in such dramatic circumstances. Even then, the corridors were empty because of the war. But now the college was filled with students of all ages and from all corners of Etheria. Almost all corners, because of course no one came from the Sorrow Islands. She was still the only person from her bleak homeland to study in Mystacor in hundreds of years. She also saw that technological progress had reached even here. There were several computer terminals here now, and small Horde cleaning bots were cleaning the floors. They even came across a hot chocolate machine, and from the looks of it, it was built here on Etheria, most likely by Horde technicians, using parts from the Fright Zone. She saw several people here who looked like Hordak's former subjects, but no one recognized her. Well, no one had seen Light Spinner's face for thirty years, though there were still some who remembered her, and most of them probably lived here in Mystacor. Therefore, she changed the color of the hair and eyes displayed by the holographic mask. Still, she felt strange walking through these corridors absolutely unrecognized by anyone. Others saw only what they expected to

see, and no one expected that while rushing to class they would pass the cursed and hated witch. There was something so wicked about it that she wanted to unleash all her dark power and scream, *Look, I'm here. The one who has been trying to kill or enslave you all for decades! Do something! Stop me!*

On the other hand, there were other reasons why no one was paying attention to her. Wrongdak was the only clone that resided in Mystacor, apparently Horde Prime made sure that none of his clones had even an ounce of magical powers. Hordak's brother looked so depressed that several students stopped to pat him on the back or even hug him. Every time this happened, Emily shot her accusatory glances. Well, maybe she was right.

However, Ireanis attracted the most attention. The elf sorceress was delighted with her stay at the magical college. She waved to all the students she passed, smiling broadly at them. She bowed politely to her teachers as she would to her colleagues, regardless of their confused looks.

“It's wonderful to be back at a university full of knowledge-hungry minds. I'm thirsty too. Do you think you can get something stronger here?” the sorceress asked her.

“We decided to quit drinking.” she said. It was technically impossible to buy alcohol in Mystakor, but students bought apple wine or strong cider in nearby villages. Lecturers and other university staff typically drank either wine made from fruit grown in gardens or herbal tinctures made by alchemists. Towards the end of her career as a teacher, she spent many lonely nights drinking and thinking about dark and grim things. "Wasn't this the beginning of all evil?"

“I know , I know, but it still dries me out.” replied the sorceress.

Finally, they reached the gallery where the statues of the most important sorcerers stood. She cringed, knowing what she was about to see. She looked down at her feet, trying not to look away.

“Oh Shady , I think it's you.” Ireanis exclaimed.

“I told you to address me like this.” She turned around and saw the statue. Her statue. It looked almost as it did when it was first placed. She was then appointed to the council as a reward for her research on entities from other dimensions. But it was cracked and blackened. She had no idea who had damaged it like that. There was one burnt candle lying under my feet.

“What does it mean? Where did this candle come from?” she asked clone, who shook his head.

“I didn't live in Mystacor. I have only visited this place three times, counting this visit…”

She thought for a moment and shrugged.

“Let's go from here. We must find the Head Sorceress.” she said in a gloomy tone.

She was cleaning old furniture in the Purple Moon Warehouse, where they kept old magical items whose uses were unknown but were potentially dangerous. This was not a suitable job for the Head Sorceress, she could have delegated other lower-ranking sorcerers or even senior students here. But she needed to calm down before her niece's wedding. Ever since the clash in the hidden chamber and the vision that had come to her when she looked at that artifact, she had felt constant anxiety. She had the impression that some evil was hiding in the previously safe corridors of her home. She couldn't forget what she had seen then, the dead monster that had risen and almost killed her and Catra and Nightgale. Catra… I guess she was too harsh on Glimmer's feline friend. The Grand Marshal saved her from having her blood sucked by the Non-Dead monster. Even though she had shocked her with an electric baton, her back still hurt, but she was also mean to the cat girl, so she didn't blame her.

She needed to calm down, because it was her responsibility to organize the wedding, and it was only a few days away. She had to pull herself together. Good thing she had Nightgale to help her . Although the girl disappeared for a few days due to, as she said, personal matters, but when she returned, she started working with renewed energy, as if she were planning her wedding herself. She was so hardworking. Maybe she should take her to the wedding and sit her in a place of honor next to the Queen. She smiled. Yes, that's a great plan, I'm sure she'll do that... Maybe she'll make Catra a tail warmer too, Scorpia liked to tell the story that the Grand Marshal, while they were in the Northern Rim, froze her tail and rubbed it so hard that it became electrified and attracted all the dust, which aroused Entrapta's fascination so much that she spent the whole day she stopped her research.. She smiled to herself, this story definitely improved her mood.

She had to admit that cleaning the warehouse was a much more labor-intensive task. No one has been here for a long time, probably even since that accident when... Shadow Weaver performed her ritual. After that, no one found any suspicious artifacts, apart from the sword of course, but that was a completely different story. Many of the items here came from the dark sorceress's private collection, and she had the distinct impression that many of them were only brought here because they were found in her apartment, as she had never seen anything that seemed dangerous, like the items locked in the Vault of Abbadus , as the dark moon associated with destructive magic was called.

For example, this mirror. It did emanate a magical aura, associated with transmitting messages over great distances, but it was nothing sinister. But it was very nice. Maybe he'll give it to Glimmer as a wedding gift... She'll definitely be delighted to discover its secrets.

It was just getting dark, and she was about to go for a portable lamp, but then she saw that the mirror did not reflect what was in the storeroom, but as if it was a room, quite tastefully decorated, with a large number of books, as if it belonged to a distinguished

and educated person. Maybe it would be good to examine the mirror first, because Glimmer would start changing her clothes in front of someone and it would be embarrassing. She was just leaning over the mirror to take a closer look at what it showed when she heard a familiar voice.

“I do not advise exploring the secrets of this mirror, because they may lead you to a path from which there is no return.”

She rolled her eyes. “Of course Shadow Weaver had to come here and ruin my mood. If he ever wants to show up at the wedding, it will be a complete disaster...

She blinked her eyes. She just heard Shadow Weaver's voice... Behind her. She turned around abruptly. Four figures stood before her. Wrong Hordak She recognized immediately, as well as Emily, who was standing next to her and chattering incomprehensibly. Hordak's nice brother was charmingly colorful, but seemed depressed. Next was a black woman, Saihe, with silver hair, whom she didn't know. She looked around the warehouse in fascination and touched every item. She didn't recognize the last person right away. Probably because of the lack of a veil on her face. Only after a moment did she manage to match her facial features to the statue standing in the hall, and she summoned a defense spell.

“They said you are dead!” she shouted, considering how she should fight the dark sorceress.

“Because I was, but now I'm standing here in front of you.” Shadow Weaver said. Cold sweat beaded her back.

“You're Non-dead!” she shouted and cast a fire spell, but the dark sorceress dispelled the spell effortlessly.

“They proper name is undead, but no, I am not one of them. However, it's interesting that you encountered these types of creatures. Until recently, I believed that, like dragons and devils, they were only characters from legends. Well, it wasn't the first

time I was wrong.” Shadow Weaver said and started walking towards her. Silver-haired Saihe looked at them and said with concern in her voice.

“Listen, girls, I know you broke up in turbulent circumstances, but it's all over now. Now you are meeting again and this is a chance for you to be together again.”

“Ireanis…” Shadow Weaver drawled, placing her hand to her temple, she felt as if her face was blurring.

“Yes, I know, only now, after this separation, did you realize that you had actually loved each other all along, even though during that time you were enemies and were constantly trying to kill each other!” the sorceress embraced them tightly and pulled them to herself. “Now you can kiss each other!”

“What did you tell her?” she growled, barely able to contain her outburst of fury and moved away from both women. It was mean and deceitful even for her. Unless Shadow Weaver really saw their relationship that way…

“I'm sorry about my companion, but she's a special person. Ireanis, Castaspella and I are not a couple, nor have we ever been... In fact, as far as I know, Castaspella is not the slightest bit interested in these matters. Now, why don't you look for some students you can... educate,” said the dark sorceress.

Sorry? Did she just say sorry? Shadow Weaver, that personification of pride and arrogance, uttered the word "sorry she thought in disbelief. Even if it was just a figure of speech, the word "sorry" coming from the mouth of someone so despicable could be unnerving. Either she was up to something particularly nefarious, or… she reached under her robes where she kept a stake, just in case… If it was a dead person or a shapeshifter like Double Trouble they will remember her.

“Oh yes, because you know, I used to be a lecturer at the University of Magaambya in Natambu , you've heard about it,

right?” silver-haired Saihe shouted.

“This is Etheria. Here, until recently, we had a very vague idea of the existence of other planets, not to mention the lost Golarion which, as the name suggests, was lost at an unspecified point in the history of the Galaxy, and now please let us talk calmly for a moment. And take Mr. Wrongdak and Emily with you, because I suspect they'll jump at the chance to take a break from my company.” said the Dark “orceress in a tone as if she was trying hard not to burst into fury.

Wrongdak looked down and said in a voice full of despair.

“Please... don't do anything to Auntie Casta”

Shadow Weaver smiled bitterly.

“This is not my intention, quite the contrary. I hope that the Head Sorceress of Mystacor, and indeed of all Etheria, will be willing to listen to what the old and mean witch has to say.

The clone nodded but looked at her as if he didn't believe her and left.

“What did you do to him?” she said angrily to Shadow Weaver. The woman sighed and said in a voice full of wry amusement.

“I recently came to the conclusion that for many people the mere fact of being near me is painful.”

Shadow Weaver being ironic towards herself? What is going on here? she thought with growing concern. But then she shook her head and asked in the most confident voice she could muster.

“What was happened to you, where were you and what were you doing? And what do you want from me... from all of us?”

Shadow Weaver smiled at the corner of her mouth.

“In sequence. I died, then I came to Aucturn, and then to Carurystal. There I took care of a creature that terrifies even me. I can tell you that much.” The dark sorceress paused, and she had the impression that she was asking a wrong question. “What am I going to do, well the answer to this question is much more complicated.” she became lost in thought, then went to the mirror and looked at it carefully for a moment, and then suddenly, with an angry movement, she covered it with a cover. “It all started a long time ago, before Adora found the sword… Before Hordak activated the portal and helped transport her to Etheria. Before... I made a rite and summoned a being whose power... Before Hordak was abandoned on Etheria... Before this hundred-fold cursed sword was forged. I have to go back to the very beginning of this grim story. I have to find Eternia”

She blinked twice.

“But Horde Prime destroyed them all. He said so himself.” she exclaimed, as if explaining the obvious to one of her students.

“He said a lot of things, and most of them weren’t true. Adora herself is the best proof of this... I won't refer to my source, because... you wouldn't consider it trustworthy, and you certainly wouldn't want to stand in front of them... But think about it. Etheria was just a research facility that was only later decided to be turned into a weapon, and yet they managed to hide it in the Despondos , do you think they wouldn't use this technology to protect their own capital? Hordak was right about one thing, Etheria is a provincial planet. The galaxy is full of wonders beyond imagination, as I can attest, though I have only seen a tiny fraction of them. But they all pale in comparison to the achievements of the First Ones. We don't really know much about their demise beyond the fact that they suddenly disappeared from galactic history, although even that we can't tell much about it because of the Gap...

“What?” she asked, feeling like she was losing the plot. “Listen, I understand that you are very interested in the First Ones and their achievements, you almost ruined the lives of Adora and most of

the inhabitants of Etheria because of that, but could you leave it and all of us alone?" she asked, refraining from screaming. She had already forgotten how irritating conversations with this woman could be.

Shadow Weaver closed her eyes and reached for the back of her neck. Her face blurred and now she could see her true face. She knew from Catra's stories that the dark sorceress looked terrible without the Mask, but when she saw it... She put her mouth behind her hand and took a deep breath. She didn't think any spell could change someone so much. She could show her face as a warning to students about what the use of dark magic can lead to... Though after a moment she realized that she had expected a much more terrible sight. Shadow Weaver, as far as she could tell, since she had no interest in such matters despite the scars and fangs and eyes like those of mythical demons, looked quite attractive. She saw victims of war, especially occupation, who suffered a much worse fate...

"She should do it right away, after all, it is only fair to have such a conversation face to face... You see, without diminishing the evil I have committed, all the tragedies that have befallen Etheria are the work of the First Ones. Light Hope, it's a good thing we never met, brought Hordak here, and many years later Adora, just to destroy all her enemies, i.e. most of the intelligent life in the galaxy. What was noticed... But we'll talk about it later... The heart was destroyed, but our planet hides many secrets, one I already knew... Far away from here in the Golarion system there is a gigantic space station inhabited by millions of beings: Absalom. It is the heart of the Galaxy both economically and politically, but also in a very literal sense. It houses the most powerful artifact we know of, the Starstone. It allows ships using Drift Drive , the most efficient form of interstellar travel, to navigate, but not only that... It is said that in ancient times it allowed mortals such as the Iomadae to sled themselves as gods."

She snorted.

“Do you mean the things that the inhabitants of Eridani talk about...” she asked skeptically, but Shadow Weaver shook her head and sighed.

-“Oh yeah, I forgot it was Etheria. For now, let's just say that it gives great power, power beyond all imagination. As I flew here through the middle of space, I discovered that there was a second similar artifact on Etheria...”

She inhaled sharply as she realized what the dark sorceress was getting at.

“This is where She-Ra draws her power from.” she said with a mixture of surprise and delight

Shadow Weaver nodded.

“Yes, and now think whether the First Ones will allow something so powerful, which has been in their possession for so many millennia, even if only theoretically, to be taken away from them... Such power... I know well how much can be done to gain greater power. I don't know what they are planning, what steps they have taken, but if what I heard is true, they intend to use their other weapon against us, perhaps the most powerful one... But this is not the only threat that awaits us, but I will tell you about it next time. our next meeting, during the Victory Day celebrations.”

She listened to Shadow Weaver carefully. This woman had been a lecturer at her university for many years before she became the monster that destroyed the lives of so many innocents and knew how to tell a story and be persuasive. If what she said was true… She didn't know if she should believe her, not after she manipulated Glimmer into activating the Heart, but could she afford to ignore her?

“What do you want from me? I'm not as powerful as Mikach, I'm not a princess and a warrior like Glimmer. I spent most of the war hiding in Mystacor and pretending it all didn't concern me since Mikah was dead.”

The dark sorceress smiled sadly.

“You are Castaspella, the chief sorceress of the only and last school of magic in Etheri and one of the largest in the galaxy. You have power, maybe not as much as mine or your brother's, but you shouldn't underestimate yourself. Besides, people like you and will listen to you... But don't tell anyone for now, if it seems that she's back, my hands will be tied and I'll lose control over the course of events, and there are still a few things I need to do before she comes back. Victory Day.” Shadow Weaver explained in her calm voice, like a parent telling a child to go to school... 'Is that how you talked to Adora all these years ? Now I have to be your pawn in this mad Game?” she thought. On the other hand, it all made sense. Since her release, Mikah has served loyally to the Rebellion, even sacrificing her life for Adora and Catra, or at least that's what everyone thought... No doubt she's changed, or maybe she's just learned to lie better... She had to make sure, so she decided to ask Shadow Weaver one more time. one question.

“During the occupation, Mikah didn't bring it up because the most important thing was to save Glimmer, and then... well, he was chipped . But when peace came, he told us everything. About you sending him to Beast Island. I won't ask if it's true, because no one who even knew you both would doubt it, but... Mikach never said why you did it. But since you are here and asking me for help... I will demand an answer... she looked at the wicked woman with hard eyes, as if she wanted to challenge her, although she knew that in the event of a fight, her chances would be slim.

The dark sorceress considered her answer for a moment, then sighed heavily and said.

“The truth is that I was very drunk at the time. Winning that battle cost me a lot. But this is not an excuse, just a statement of fact. Besides, I came to Mikah when he was locked in a cell and made him an offer... I offered him to serve me in exchange for his life... of course he refused and... he called me a monster, a twisted bogeyman and that his teacher died many years ago.

Well, then I said that then there was no one in the entire Fright Zone who could save him from a fate worse than death. Even though we were both wrong then."

She frowned and asked.

"What do you mean?"

"Mikah saved himself when he got to his place of exile, and Shadow Weaver always lived in Light Spinner's heart" Shadow Weaver said and looked at her inquisitively with those terrible yellow eyes. She squeezed her eyes and mouth shut. *If you tried to lie and cheat… then everything would be easier. Did you have to be so honest?*

"All right, I'll help you. Just don't make me regret it later." she said, and the Dark Sorceress started to leave, but suddenly she stopped and asked with a shyness she would never have expected from her.

"Who burns a candle under my statue and why is it so damaged?"

She looked at her seriously

"It's Catra. Every year on the day Shadow Weaver dies... on the day you die, she burns one candle for every good deed you did for her and Adora. And the statue was destroyed by Mikah right after he finished his studies. This resulted in a minor scandal, but much less than he had expected." she explained to the woman, who was probably more gloomy than usual now. She shuddered as if these words brought back many unpleasant memories, turned on the mask and left.

As soon as Nightgale saw her mother, she stopped dead in her tracks, but Shadow Weaver obviously didn't recognize her. Why should it be any different? She didn't even know she existed. She couldn't even guess what Hordak had done. Still, she felt pain. For a moment she felt like introducing herself to her and showing her

her true face. But now was definitely not the right time for it. Here in Mystacor it could be very dangerous. She wouldn't die, she was almost sure of that, but it would mean ruining all her plans. It was much easier for her to recognize Hordak's right hand. She felt its power, great and terrible, and more than once she looked at the statue of the Light Spinner. She tried to find a similarity in her features, and she succeeded. Still, she was amazed that absolutely no one in all of Mystacor was aware of who had showed up at their college. As they say, the darkest is in the light of day...

She knew that Shadow Weaver was alive, the Voice from the Shadow had told her about it, and that he would come to Etheria with a wonderful companion... It was definitely not her father's strangely dressed clone , nor a Horde Droid. She wondered if it was the silver-haired Saihe , because she sensed great power from her, but she was looking around like a child in a candy store, so she had doubts. Shadow Weaver then asked where the Head Sorceress was and told her that she was cleaning out one of the warehouses. Ignoring her, the four of them left and she secretly followed them. She almost ran into them when the sorcerers sent the others away to talk about something important without any additional witnesses. She wasn't able to overhear them, although considering that she didn't hear screams or the sounds of magical explosions, the conversation was conducted in an unexpectedly calm atmosphere. Then Shadow Weaver left, dejected, and soon after, Castaspella left the warehouse, angry and as gloomy as the dark sorceress. She waited until her apparent boss left, then went to the warehouse to find out what the sorcerers were talking about. At first she didn't see anything, but then she saw a light blue light coming from under the cover of the large mirror. As a servant of the Creeping Chaos, she knew it was idiotic to approach glowing magical objects, but she approached it anyway and ripped off the cover. She saw a room, quite cozy... and a person sitting in a chair. At first she mistook them for a Saihe , but although similar, they were significantly different from her mother's species. First of all, horns sprouted from their head, making her look like a legendary tiefling. They also had four

fingers on her hands. But what was most remarkable was her skin. Blue, sparkling as if stars were reflecting in it. With her magical vision, she saw that the bright spots covering her were connected by lines, forming inscriptions in the language of the First Ones, which, unfortunately, she was unable to read. After a while, the figure noticed her, got up and approached her, looking at her with curiosity, as if she were a small, interesting animal, that entered his house. She flinched, but now it was too late, she had to know the identity of this creature. She hesitated, and then and then she asked, drawing illusory letters in the air.

“They call me... Defect. Who are you?” she asked, using the first name she received from her father. She preferred not to reveal her real name. The person tilted they head to the side and began to write himself in illusory letters just like her.

“I am Aaravos . He, Him , if that interests you... “he explained and bowed courtly.

“Who are you... I've never heard of anyone like you...” she asked, unable to contain her curiosity.

“You didn’t heard of us because there are only a few of us left.” he explained to her with theatrical sadness on his face.

“Elf? It's an ancient name for Saihe ... But you are not like them.” she said, baffled.

“We were changed a long time ago... I once talked to a Saihe woman. But that was a long time ago. No one has visited me for a long time... No one from your world, anyway.” he explained to her without taking his eyes off her

“Our world? Or our planet?” she asked, smiling with a bit of superiority. But Aaravos just raised an eyebrow.

“So you remembered that you are part of the universe. What about the Heart of Etheria? Ahh, I see from your reaction that you know what I am talking about.”

She cursed inwardly, but since she had already betrayed herself, there was no other option and she had to tell the truth, although she was afraid that nothing good would come of it.

“Yes, it was destroyed five years ago. By She-Ra …”

Aaravos nodded thoughtfully. And then he said more to himself than to her.

“That clears up many things. That's why the boy was able to cast spells despite the protection... That means we don't have much time..”- he looked at her again. “What about Light Spinner , that woman I was talking to earlier. Was the ritual successful?”

“This is a very controversial issue. The being came … but changed her…”

Aaravos smiled in amusement.

-“So it worked...” he tilted his head to the side and quickly cast the spell. She felt her illusion dissipate. The Star Elf smiled.

“Impressive... An illusion that does not create a false image, but influences the observer's mind. I didn't know you had discovered this technique... You, too, are an extraordinary creature, proof that the ritual worked better than I expected... You were artificially created, just like me... But I sense that we have something else in common. – he reached under his robes and pulled out an upside-down Ankh. Symbol of Creeping Chaos.

That woman, Nightgale, didn't inspire her confidence. At first glance, she saw that a strange aura was emanating from her. She was definitely using illusions to hide her face, although she guessed that many war victims used this magic because of their scars. But there was something else about her, she felt like she was looking into a mirror. But it was absurd. She considered telling Castaspelia about it , but I guess the Head Sorceress of Mystacor had checked her second-in-command, right?

She found Wrongdak in the garden, talking to someone who looked like a Gnome. She was surprised to see that she wore the Serenae symbol around her neck. When they saw her, she nodded and hurried away, and the clone looked at her with fear in her eyes, but she smiled back at him and said.

“Everything worked out fine. Castaspella agreed to help us.”

Hordak's younger brother blinked several times, as if he didn't believe what he was hearing.

“You… enchanted her?” he asked and she let out a short laugh.

“Oh, I was just being honest, absolutely honest, because, believe it or not, my intentions towards your friends are good.” she said gently. He seemed skeptical, but she didn't care. It's important that he doesn't spill anything to anyone.

“Where's Ireanis?” she asked and then she heard a loud scream and a clatter coming from the side corridor, from which Ireanis ran out after a moment, accompanied by Emily.

“Shhh Daisy! I had funny adventure. By complete accident, I came across a group of students and I decided to show them something, so I went to a side room and summoned a minor demon, just for fun, I think I made a mistake and summoned Vrock instead of Quasit , but luckily we defeated him together. And I became a hero, because I don't think anyone realized it was my doing, but... just in case. We should run away?” the elven sorceress was saying, and Emily was chattering away from the side. She sighed and said.

“I'm slowly starting to think, my dear Ireanis, that you are my reflection, but in a distorting mirror.”

The silver-haired woman grimaced painfully.

“No, at least you're not a coward.” she said, and suddenly feeling sad, she walked down the bright corridors of Mystacor.

"But we won!"

She kissed her beloved on the cheek, and she snored sweetly and tried to hug her, although it wasn't easy sitting in the Silverwing seat, so she moved closer to her. She could smell her scent mixed with her own, she didn't know a more beautiful scent, it was something that people with a weaker sense of smell couldn't understand. Despite the grim news, they made love that night. Adora was so eager for her touch and kisses that, despite her exhaustion, as soon as they rested after the first time, she initiated a second, and then a third... And then, in the moment of greatest elation, they toppled the tent. Then they lay naked and cuddled together for a good two-quarters of an hour, giggling like idiotic teenagers and listening to hear if the other members of the expedition had heard anything. When they figured everyone was asleep, they quietly put on their tent and put it back together again. They were sure they didn't wake up anyone until the morning... Then, when they sat down for breakfast together, Lance and George tried very hard not to look at them and talk about the weather, but Netossa was watching them, grinning. But it was Entrapta who spoke first.

“Did you feel the tremors at night? It was so strange. I had no idea that this region was seismically active.”

She choked on her tea with butter and Adora had to pat her on the back. But that wasn't the end, because then Frosta spoke.

“The legends of the Kingdom of Snow tell of two stone giants who, on the darkest night, “wrestle” so much that the earth shakes.” she said with an absolutely innocent face. Well, sometimes they forgot that Frosta was almost the same age as them when Adora found the sword. Melog also began to rub himself against her girlfriend, because he wanted to add his scent

to that of his companion. She felt herself blushing, and Adora was beet red.

“You guys are horrible. Really horrible.” she said with her face hidden behind the cup. When everyone laughed, she snorted, but she wasn't offended. Then her beloved embraced her in front of everyone and kissed her, and then they laughed too.

The way back was more difficult than towards the City. Everyone, including Adora , was exhausted and Netossa's Hand was still sore. In addition, her fiancée did not take any equipment with her for a high-mountain expedition in such cold. She didn't even have warm clothes, she left a backpack with food on Icarus , which she took with her when she went on a trip to the wilderness of that planet, although she didn't say why she went there. They did not tell others about the dark news her fiancée had brought with her. Glimmer should hear this before everyone else. No one noticed their mood, except Georgie, who slowed down and asked Adora ...

- Did something happen... Where you came from. You know you can tell us anything.

Her fiancée grimaced painfully, adjusted the blanket she had wrapped herself in during the hike and said.

- Yes, but Glimmer should hear about it first because... it concerns her first and foremost.

- I know you want to help, but there's nothing that can be done in this case... Only Glimmer and Mikach can decide what to do next. – she added, smiling sadly at Bow's father and hugging her girlfriend.

She herself had no idea what they could do yet. She was glad that Glimmer's mother was alive... But she was terrified of what had happened to her. She had no idea what had happened to her over the years, but it certainly hadn't been good. She barely knew her at all, but she knew she wouldn't become a pirate, under any

circumstances. She knew all too well what suffering and injustice could do to someone. What a dark path such cruelties can lead. She got off it herself with great difficulty, but many people, including Adora and Glimmer, still bore the scars of what she had done... Wherever Angela ended up, it must have been a terrible place.

That's why she was going to postpone telling her the truth about herself, about what she had learned about herself. It wasn't that important, after all, she was still Catra, a child of the Fright Zone and a resident, where she was from made absolutely no difference. Her companions looked at her questioningly, but she answered them in the negative, shaking her head. Eventually, Netossa talked her out of it as Adora followed suit.

"And did you tell her?" she asked in a much too loud whisper. She looked around and replied in a similar tone.

"Now is not a good time to make such a confession. Something happened there on Icarus ... I can't say anything yet, but things got terribly complicated." she sighed and added. – It's nothing that threatens all of Etheri or your family. No new evil has emerged from the shadows, we are past that. – She smiled sadly, and the ruler of Armoria sighed.

"It was a difficult week. I didn't think we would have so many adventures, damn, there were more of them than during the months of the war. And to think that the only thing that worried me at the beginning was whether you are pregnant." said the former general, and then she heard Adora scream.

“What's it mean you are pregnant?”

“It's starting again.” She thought, hiding her face in her hands.

“I'm not pregnant, none of us are, although I can't vouch for Shogi , I'm also afraid that there is another Alice inside Alice , with another Alice inside. I wouldn't have come up with this idea

without discussing all this with you.” she felt herself blushing. Adora walked up to her and kissed her.

“Don't worry, honey, I understand everything. I know you would definitely make the right decision, darling.”

She felt tears welling up in her eyes.

"Because I just ate a piece of weird food and what Glimmer has been eating lately and… there were a few other things…" she sniffed and Melog began to rub against her comfortingly, all blue.

:Wait, Glimmer ear... a weird food? – Netossa asked, her eyes wide. “Oh,” she covered her mouth with her hands. She didn't understand what she meant, but it didn't matter to her now. All that mattered now was Adora's closeness and warmth. She couldn't imagine losing her, having someone take her away from her. She was willing to burn the entire world to prevent this, and she wouldn't regret it.

The final stage of the road to Silverwing passed in a much more pleasant atmosphere. Frosta radiated joy, even though at the end of the journey she fell asleep on Shogi's back . It was her first great adventure and she had the right to feel proud, after all, she was the one who practically saved them, or at least she helped a lot. She will definitely constantly tell them all, especially Glimmer, about this trip and well, she deserves it. The others seemed happy too. Lance and George talked about their new discoveries the whole way, happy and excited as if they had become a good twenty years younger. Netossa smiled full of joyful triumph, but at the same time it was clear that she wanted to return to her peaceful family life. Even Entrapta, for whom desolate places without researchable technology were certainly not very interesting, made some discoveries here and watched Shogi with fascination, because of which Melog became jealous. They were also in this mood, despite the bad news Adora brought.

When they reached the vehicles, Frosta, who was nodding off, decided to continue riding on top of Shogi , who wrapped his tentacle-like straps around her. So they had one additional vehicle, but Adora decided that she wanted me to go with her in one vehicle, so Netossa went alone and Entrapta went with Bow's dads . During Lunch, while they were eating smoked meat pancakes, Adora took her aside and began to tell her about the events on Icarus.

“At first I had a dream. A stupid nightmare, or so I thought, but now I don't know.” said her fiancée in an uncertain voice. When she heard this, she flattened her ears because she remembered that dream with a dark city and a girl with two-colored eyes. Adora swallowed and continued.

“And when I woke up, I killed the clock again... But then I had a public speech and there was this Ivory Claw. She... and she accused me of everything we went through being planned, that we had been working with Horde Prime from the very beginning. And then... I ran away and decided to go on a solo trip to think everything over. I rested for some time and then these kids found me... Itel, Rosie and Eti. They were nice and funny but... they came from outside the empire, they never knew Horde Prime ...”

“That's... wonderful... It's good to hear that someone out there was able to have a normal, happy childhood.” she said, although she felt a twinge of uncertainty. Glimmer was very afraid of what might lurk beyond the borders of the empire. The first people Adora met seemed nice, but she remembered what happened with Glimmer's mom.

Adora hesitated and said in a serious voice

“Rosie was very happy and joyful, but the others... They lost their world... Kesler... the Swarm destroyed it. I don't know exactly what it is, but it's terrifying and powerful.

She felt the hairs on the back of her neck stand up. She heard both of these names in her dream... It couldn't just be a

coincidence. Maybe she "heard" everything when she was chipped. Even if they hadn't heard of Horde Prime , he might have heard of their world.

“And then they took me to the rest of their friends who came across Scorpia and Perfuma and oh ...” Adora made a face as if she had just remembered something. ” Entrapta, I have something to tell you.” she said to the inventor, who tried to cut a piece of Shogi's fur , but he escaped with hair that was as prehensile as hers.

“Yes?” asked the purple-haired woman who was next to her in two bounds.

“I'm sorry I didn't tell you earlier, but when I was on Icarus, I met Wrong Hordak and Emily. They both are fine! – said her fiancée, smiling cheerfully for the first time since yesterday's conversation. Entrapta jumped happily and wrapped her arms and hair around Adora .

“Oh, that's wonderful! How is he? Does Emily remember to apply rust remover regularly? Did they make new friends?!” she said in an excited voice. Adora nodded.

“Yes, very many, a bit unusual ones, and I think they are flying here to Etheria, they will be at the Victory Day celebrations.” now Adora became serious again “I met someone else there. Lady Cala Grayskull . She comes from a planet called Carurystal and claims that her ancestor was Mara. She was... amazing, but then...” she gave her a significant look, but fortunately Entrapta was interested in something else and did some calculations for a moment, until she finally spoke.

“Assuming that at least a thousand years have passed, there could have been as many as forty generations, so although we do not know the potential lifespan of the First Ones or their descendants, at least theoretically, Lady Cala has... a very small fraction of Mara's blood.” the purple-haired woman explained .

“Yeah, she said something like that, without all the scientific terms. She also travels with Wrong Hordak, and she'll probably be coming to Etheria soon, so you'll probably all meet her.” Adora said, scratching her head and smiling with an effort. Entrapta looked up from her Datapad and tilted her head.

“Did something happen? You are usually much more energetic and smile much more. Catra also looks exhausted and very stressed despite the... relaxing activity tonight...” she looked at them and they both started to blush. But they must have looked very exhausted. If even Entrapta noticed that something was wrong, it means that everyone would see it.

“You know, this is quite a personal topic to talk about...” she said, flattening her ears.

“Why? This usually works great. I checked on Hordak. You know how he always gets stressed when something goes wrong. But after sex he is always nice and relaxed.” Entrapta xplained

They both stiffened with very stupid expressions.

“I don't want to live with such knowledge in my head!” Adora moaned.

“These images will probably never disappear... “ she said in a dead voice.

“Hmmm, I once constructed a memory recovery device. She helped Hordak a lot, but to erase the memory... Hmmm.” the inventor moved aside, engaged in another topic. They looked at each other and laughed happily, but after a while she added.

“I think I lost a bet.”

“What bet?” Adora asked.

“You see, I made a bet with Glimmer and Bow about Entrapta and Hordak doing it and...” she hid her face in her hands. – I think I'll have to sing at our wedding.

They laughed again.

Netossa had to admit that the dressing created by Shogi had worked wonders, but her hand still hurt after prolonged exercise, so she decided to hand over the ruders to Entrapta and went to see what the others were up to. Catra gently stroked Adora's head, who was sleeping and snoring loudly. Lance and George showed each other photos taken of the remnants of the Elder Things, glowing with youthful energy. Oh, she guessed it's going to happen so much *things* between the shelves of their library. Frosta was sitting in her chair with a concentrated expression, tinkering with something, and her new friend was now holding almost dog head in her lap. Melog, in turn, had his head under his mistress's arm. Suddenly, the ruler of the Kingdom of Snow screamed loudly.

"Ready!" she unfastened the seatbelts and then ran to Adora and Catra. The blonde-haired warrior looked around with panicked eyes until her girlfriend calmed her down. Frosta smiled broadly and spoke

"It was supposed to be a gift from me for your wedding, but since we had an adventure together, I can give it to you now." and she handed Adora a bone necklace decorated with various symbols important to the culture of the inhabitants of her kingdom, and she handed Catra a flute made of black wood. – "I did it all myself. It took me some time, but everything worked out."

"Is beautiful." said Adora, immediately putting on the gift. Catra looked at the flute with a smile and then took the mouthpiece into her mouth. And she started playing. She didn't expect that they taught such things in the Horde, although no one would expect dancing lessons either, and Catra and Adora put on quite a show at that ball... Well, no one knew what the dark sorceress could have thought of. Only this melody was strange, shrill and irritating. It hurt not only the ears, but also the heart and even the soul itself. There was something so alien about her. Was this

music taught in the Horde? Was Shadow Weaver happy when listen this melody? With dark bitch everything is possible. Only Adora was also staring at her fiancée, amazed, or even shocked. And Catra didn't stop playing. It was as if she had fallen into a trance. Everyone looked at her with growing disbelief, even Entrapta looked out from the cockpit. Melog also looked confused and flattened his ears. Finally, Adora gave her a sharp nudge. Catra looked around in confusion, as if she had just woken up.

“Honey, you're fine?” Adora said with concern in her voice, hugging her girlfriend. Catra looked at the flute, flinched as if she were afraid of it, and let it fall from her hands.

“Yes... everything, I just remembered something.” she smiled with an effort.

“You know, if it's not the right gift, I'll think of something else.” Frosta said with guilt in her voice, but Catra and Adora hugged her.

“It’s great, I just had a dream recently in which I heard this melody...” said the cat-like girl, trying to be cheerful.

She loved adventures, but in her opinion, the best part of them was the moment when you came home to rest and then reminisce with friends. During this trip, she met two new people. True, it will be difficult to talk to Shogi, at least for now, and Nightgale will now live with Lonnie, but they will meet again someday. Maybe Nightgale will even convince Lonnie to make peace with Adora, Catra and Glimmer and they will all celebrate Victory Day together. Yes, she had to prepare for the celebrations, because she would be the main bodyguard. He needs to rest and train... Although it is not known who could attack them now. They'll definitely get along with Lonnie soon, and Horde Ultimate and the Brothers are too afraid of all of them.

She was looking forward to the celebrations. There will be music, good food, lots of sweets and guests from Other Worlds... Maybe she will meet Empress Eridani and finally find out what it is about being emperor that the Chancellor keeps encouraging her to accept this title. When they landed at the airport, she was the first to leave. It wasn't the biggest port on Etheria, there was only one ship here now, a strange one, I think it was from the Aquarius. She was the first to exit Netossa's vehicle and rode on her new mount friend towards her palace. She waved to the people she passed, most of whom looked at her in surprise and didn't wave back. Well, they were probably surprised to see Shogi, whose eyes wandered around his body to better see the people he passed. Well, She was sure they'll get used to him soon, he was such a sweetheart after all. She wanted to be the first in the castle to bring her friends the key to the armory. After all, that was the main reason for this trip, and I'm sure everyone would be happy, and then Glimmer would praise her. The ride didn't take long, Shogi was very fast after all, she couldn't wait to race against Swiftwind.

She reached the icy walls of her palace and dismounted from her steed and walked towards her abode as the guards stared at her with terribly stupid expressions. She walked proudly, but then the guards suddenly blocked her path with blades. She stopped in surprise and tried to move on, but the guards were persistent.

“What do you do?” she asked, confused. “Let me in!” she exclaimed, feeling growing anxiety. After all, she just wanted to enter her castle. The guards looked at each other as if wondering which of them should tell her something. Finally, the captain of the guard she knew as the Blue Walrus came. He looked at her apologetically, then said.

“We received orders that we are not allowed to let Frosta into the national ice palace. You were deprived of power by the will of the tribal council and the chancellor. Please wait here for the Chancellor to tell you the resolutions of the Republic of Snow government... I'm sorry, but there's not much I can do except bring you something warm to drink. Some sweets or snack...” she

had the impression that he wanted to tell her something else between the words, but she couldn't catch what.

“Some sweets or a snack?” she said quietly in an dull voice. This did not make sense! How could they deprive her of power... Not let her into her castle... it makes no sense! “I want to talk to the chancellor! Let me explain it all. If this is a joke, it's completely unfunny.”

The guards looked ashamed… That was what scared her the most. They didn't even have the courage to look her in the eye. Blue Walrus sighed and went to the palace. She paced back and forth nervously, glaring at the guards, who looked scared. That's good... Then she heard Adora's cheerful voice behind her

“Are we waiting for something?”

She felt her heart stop in her chest. She forgot about her friends. She turned to them, they had just come on foot. She forced a carefree smile and said cheerfully.

“No, nothing happened, just minor problems with the sewage system!”

Adora frowned and nodded slowly, but Catra and Netossa exchanged worried glances. Melog nudged her comfortingly with his muzzle, and Shogi rubbed against her side. Finally, the palace gates opened and the chancellor stood there. He was dressed in a beautiful and expensive fur coat from some creature not found on Etheria . “When did he buy them?” she wondered. Immediately after that, she saw something that made her blush with anger. Around his neck he wore a medallion made of bluestone. It was an ancient symbol of power worn by the princesses of the kingdom of Snow since... forever! By what right did he appropriate it…

“What... What does that mean!” she shouted furiously and felt that everything around her was covered with frost.

The Chancellor smiled triumphantly as he stood at the gate of the outer wall and said.

“Miss Frosta! You. my dear, by the will of the people of the Republic of Snow, were deprived of your title and the privileges associated with it. All your property passes into the hands of the people. Please surrender voluntarily and you will be taken to a designated house where you will remain under house arrest until a decision is made about the fate of you and your runestone.

“But why? What have I done?” She asked, holding back tears with difficulty. “Chancellor, you are my friend...”

The Chancellor raised his head proudly and said, almost shouting at her.

“First of all, from now on, Comrade Chancellor and I have never been your friend, only a subordinate. Now to answer your question. You did a lot and at the same time absolutely nothing. You embroiled our country in a war and, driven by personal sympathies, concluded an alliance against the interests of your subjects. And you stand by him, even though the so-called Queen Glimmer has brought the Galactic Horde here, and now she is playing the great leader of the universe, forgetting about her own planet. And your last whim has overflowed the cup of bitterness.”

“What whim? You… You liar and cheater!” she shouted. She felt tears streaming down her face.

“You gave away the treasures of your country to foreign people connected with the queen.” he pointed at the confused Lance and George. “You took two people there with you who were the leaders of the Horde.” he pointed at Catra and Entrapta , who was wagging her tail furiously and looking at them with surprise. Without consulting anyone. In the name of childish desires, you abandoned your responsibilities. We need an ice queen with a heart as cold as winter itself, not a spoiled brat seeking the approval of the kingdom's enemies! You are not fit to be a ruler. You let us all down”

Then she screamed.

She had to admit that making love with Catra had helped her de-stress a bit, and now she had almost forgotten about the events on Icarus . It can wait, she wanted to spend this moment with her beloved one. They were together, that's when they were the strongest, unstoppable. They can handle anything and help Glimmer get through even the worst hardships.

Then Catra started playing. She didn't know that her fiancée was so musical, but she was happy that she had found a new talent, even if the melody she played was so eerie. Catra, however, seemed scared afterwards, but she didn't want to say why, she only said that she would explain everything soon. She agreed to give her time, but not too much, she had learned from Bow not to let others keep their worries in their own hearts, because it only makes everything worse...

And then they were witnesses... She didn't know what the princess' dismissal was called, perhaps deprincessship ? She had no idea that something like this was even possible. She could only feel her anger rising at how cruelly this man had treated the ice princess, but her anger was nothing compared to Catra's fury, which she growled.

“The fucking Shadow Weaver family.”

Netossa nodded and added.

“As soon as I find her, I'll beat her like that...”

She didn't understand what she was talking about, but when she heard Catra swearing, she looked at her with surprise, but then she pursed her lips and was about to defend her young friend when she screamed. Suddenly the air became icy cold, and a blue-white glow began to radiate from Frosta. The tundra around them froze, frost appeared on all of their cheeks. Breathing

became downright painful. In addition, Shogi took on his true form, the monstrous Shogoth.

“I'll calm down Frosta , you stop Shogi as She-Ra, otherwise he'll eat that bastard. Entrapta, call for some help, Netossa, make a net and you “ she turned to Bow's fathers “Just stay away from all this.”

She nodded to her fiancée. And she screamed...

“For the Honor of the Grayskull.” and she felt power flowing through her. Multi-colored light flashed and she became She- Ra'a, towering over everyone in her height. She transformed at the right moment because that idiot chancellor only intended to make the situation worse because he said it with contempt.

“And you just proved to everyone that you are not fit to be ruler. You can't even control your own power! And you brought us a monster here.”

Frosta screamed again, and Shogoth lunged at the Chancellor. She stood in front of him, shielding the annoying man, while Melog pushed him to the ground and growled menacingly. Instead of a sword, she now had a wide shield.

“Shogi, look at me. I know you're mad because this guy hurt your friend, but it's really not worth eating him. You'll only complicate everything, and you'll probably get indigestion and all.” she explained and then the monster calmed down a bit.

Meanwhile, Catra sat down next to Frost and said.

“Frosta, Frosta… the Terrible Ice Bane!”

The ice princess turned to the cat girl and said.

“How can he do that! We fought Horde Prime, Hordak , and even you…. We risked our lives for them. For all of Etheria. After all, we won... We won in the end. Why does he want to arrest me! We were the good guys, right?” her glow dimmed and the youngest

of their alliance began to sob. Catra knelt down next to her and hugged her.

“Everything will be fine... We'll manage somehow... Glimmer will definitely think of something. We will take you to her…

“NO! I can't face her now. I failed her. I failed you all...”

The Chancellor stood up when Melog release him.

“You will all be arrested...” the man began, but Catra looked at him with her cat-like, two-colored eyes as menacingly as she hadn't done since the war.

“Listen to me, you son of a bitch... I don't know much about Etherian law, but I'm pretty sure you can't arrest someone without a reason. And if you want to arrest us, you have stand against the most warrior of princesses, a long-time Rebel general, a brilliant weapons specialist, two ancient beasts, a slayer of Horde Prime, and me, a Shadow Weaver ward and, believe me, i'm the scariest one out of all of them.

It's probably only now that the Chancellor realized what he had gotten himself into. He turned pale and swallowed loudly, looking nervously from side to side.

“Okay, you can leave, but don't you dare come back here again.” he threatened, but his voice was breaking.

“But we dare to come back. You can be sure of that.” Catra said, smiling evilly.

Cooperation

Bina felt her head starting to hurt. What in the name of devils and demons tempted her to send Eti with Itel and Rosie to this tavern. Itel's hotheadedness, Rosie's kindness, and Eti's unhingedness were the perfect combination for disaster. Itel was looking for the most dangerous place possible for them to go to, Rosie was so nice and friendly that everyone let their guard down, and then Eti did something insane and everything went up in flames. Together they were the triad of doom. And because of the romantic tension between them, it facilitated the escalation of chaos... And she, as their guardian, should have anticipated all this. They may have all been of age, but they couldn't be called sensible. So if they did something crazy, it was her fault that they did it. Although luckily Lika and Alatar were not there, otherwise the disaster would have been complete.

As soon as this Ikeshi brought the news that someone had started a brawl in the local bar, she broke into a run and immediately turned back when she realized that she didn't know exactly where to go. So she let Huntara lead them. The orc warrior seemed shocked by what she learned. However, Bina was sure that the time for a real shock would come when she got there and met Eti. She had to admit that this woman was in pretty good shape. She had a hard time keeping up with her, let alone Alatar, who was panting so hard it seemed like he was going to spit out his lungs. Only Lilka kept up with Huntara, she obviously couldn't let look weak in eyes of another orc, even if that orc didn't know she was an orc. Once they were in place, she doubled over and gasped, and Alatar fell to the ground, gasping. Huntara and Lilka, they didn't even break a sweat... It's so unfair... He needs to start training more.

They stood on a scarlet rock and looked at the smoking building. It was made of stone, leather and bone. It looked quite menacing, if not for the neon sign depicting a colorful flower and hang

laundry drying on a line. A large number of Bone Shelter patrons gathered near the skull that served as the entrance and attempted to extinguish the fire, with only moderate success.

“You know, it could have been worse. – she said to Huntara , who stood with her mouth open in disbelief, staring at the smoking building. Then the orca turned to her and spoke in an angry voice.

“How worse? Gang wars broke out in the wastelands for things like this?”

She grinned.

“It's still standing, and considering that Itel is a Solarian and Eti likes explosions, I would expect smoking ruins here.”

Lilka nodded with absolute seriousness.

“It's only because we weren't there. We're really good at breaking things. I swing my axe, and Alatar breathes fire.”

Dragonkin lowered his wings in shame.

“Lilka, you are spreading offensive stereotypes!

The redhead tilted her head to the side.

“You spread them yourself when you breathe fire... But they are very nice flames! Then everything burns so beautifully!”

Huntara , whoever she was and whatever she had been through, wasn't eager to meet her kids, so she just stared at them as if she wasn't sure if they were joking. She walked up to the tall warrior and patted her on the back.

“Welcome to my world.” she said in a friendly voice and moved towards the concourse.

She had nothing against Catra. She respected her for her courage, bravery and persistence. She just didn't want the girl to show up here unnecessarily. She stuck a stick into an anthill here and then left. She told this directly to the Grand Marshal and she agreed with her and respected this request. And now she was standing in front of a crowd of her gang members who were demanding an explanation.

“Is Catra back to regain power?” said the hyenaperson

“Will Brightmoon take away our freedom!” exclaimed the emaciated scorpion.

“These were new tables.” said Doris, the bartender and her ex, despairingly .

“Silence!” she shouted and the crowd calmed down a bit and she started talking. “I'll take care of everything, you have my word on that, but first, be quiet instead of babbling one by one, or I'll beat the crap out of you. Has anyone died?”

“Rash and Rush have hearing problems, Gorgo had a broken jaw.” explained the gloomy lizard technician. “And Sculy …” He pointed to the snake-woman hugging her knees and swaying mechanically. “She got hit by that girl. Good thing she didn't kill her!”

“Eti usually doesn't seriously hurt anyone, Itel is the hot-headed and dangerous one.” Bina explained, smiling nervously.

“Usually?” she snapped at the burgundy-haired woman, who just shrugged. Meanwhile, Lilka approached Sculy, who kept saying "There are two now", and showed her the picture on the datapad. She was too far away to see it clearly, but it seemed to her that it was a catgirl with a disturbing resemblance to Catra, staring menacingly ahead and giving someone an insulting gesture with her metal hand. When Sculy saw the photo, she screamed and started crawling on all fours as far as she could. The red-haired girl smiled happily and called to Bina.

“Yes, it was definitely Eti!”

“I didn't guess that at all.” Bina muttered sarcastically and turned to everyone gathered.

“Hey. Recently, one of my wards started a brawl here. As we all know, they happen regularly in places like this because we bad to the bones. I know that because I've spent almost my entire life in places like this, as have my kids. I know my warsds and I know that they don't start fights for any reason. Had someone stared or, gods forbid, touched her?” she asked, looking at the gathered people smiling conciliatingly. They looked at each other in surprise and several nodded. “Well, you see.” she continued. “None of us likes it when someone stares at us and then everyone wants to punch that person, and if someone fucked you up, it means you deserved the fuck and there's no point in making a big deal out of it, just solve the problem by yourself... And so I'm just saying that this girl with white hair recently fought with the living dead, the green-haired, pointed-eared girl survived the destruction of her own planet, and this cat-like girl was trained from birth to be a murderer, so you can say that you're lucky that nothing serious happened to you. And apart from her appearance, she has nothing in common with Catra. She's just a wronged girl, who has problems with aggression, raised in barracks by a megalomaniac and his right-hand woman…” Bina explained. Everyone stared at her with very gloomy eyes. She sighed and whispered to the woman with burgundy hair.

“You just described Catra from a few years ago...”

“I guessed...” Bina said with a smile plastered on her lips. Scorpion stepped forward and said.

“I remember the last time Catra was here. A week later she tried to fuck up the planet because she was pissed off”

Then Lilka looked thoughtful and said.

“Eti could probably do the same if she was in storm days or really bored...

“You're not helping.” Bina said through gritted teeth, and then added. “I promise to compensate you for the damage...” she looked at the snakewoman, who was staring blankly ahead.” To pay for psychotherapy and, most importantly, to share with you the treasures that we will find in the tomb of the famous Mara, the previous She- Ra , because I recently came into possession of maps leading to it.” she waved the sheets of paper that Goldeneyes gave them, “And if you don't trust me, the terrible and invincible Huntara here has pledged to personally ensure that I fulfill her part of the contract.

She clenched her jaw tightly, trying not to show anger or surprise. She was going to find the tomb anyway, but alone, or with trusted friends, and she wanted to give what she found there to Adora and Glimmer, not to the regulars of the Bone Haven, who were a bunch of greedy bastards. Only if she said something now, another brawl would break out and she would look like an idiot or a fraud, she could already see the burning greed in their eyes. Will deal with them again...

“Lady Huntara is an Orc, and orcs never ever break their word, always act honorably, and always wash behind their ears. “Lilka began to tell in a cheerful voice, focusing everyone's attention on her. “I'm an Orca, so I know best what we are like.”

And there was silence as everyone tried to fit what they had just heard into the Huntara they knew, which was probably beyond their abilities. Hers too. She took a deep breath and spoke in a tone that brooked no objections.

“It's as this woman said, we will find Mara's Tomb and obtain its riches, although of course I will keep most of the treasures, for I am the ruler of the Scarlet Wastes and if anyone doesn't agree with it, draw out their weapons and fight with me.” she looked at everyone menacingly, and when she noticed that Lilka was looking at them with admiration, she growled at her.

“And you have to explain to me what's going on with these orcs!”

The red-haired girl smiled broadly, her eyes shining with pure delight. However, Bina made a face that suggested that she had gotten herself into something very smelly.

“Let's go. I guess now we have to find your people and make sure they don't do any more damage. Only if you don't keep up, I'll leave you behind.” She said, but Bina grinned and said

“Hey, we have transport, and the girls have transmitters, and even Itel isn't crazy enough to throw them away. Oh, look there!” The burgundy-haired woman pointed to a vehicle driving towards them, surrounded by a cloud of red stripes. When it came close, she saw that it was a military transport with eskers and teeth painted on it.

“Huntara , meet Crusher. Crusher, this is Huntara.” Bina said. The door opened and she was horrified to see that the interior was empty.

“Huntara is an orc, like Wagar. She just doesn't know it yet.” Lilka explained, and then a voice came from inside the vehicle.

“Listen Hunti , it's good that you're here. Countless enemies await us here. Bugs, birds, small cars, But together we will face them, we are invincible!”

She really was too old for all this.

Tung Lashor bared his fangs in a smile when he heard the news his subordinates brought him. First he learned that new guests had arrived in the Scarlet Waste, his wasteland. Of course, his friends didn't know the real reasons for his interest in that group. They probably thought he wanted to rob them and took the technologically advanced equipment they brought with them. Maybe that's what he'll do! But he must question them first. He looked at his whip, metal and segmented, a real gem that he had

bought from recently Icarus during his secret trip there. He was completely broke and had to take out a loan on the account of Lonnie and her People's Rebellion. After all, they were friends and allies, so he would definitely understand and pay as soon as he found out about everything. Unfortunately, he didn't discover anything there, but it didn't change anything, he had been loyal for twenty-five years and had been carrying out the mission entrusted to him by the management with great trust.

And then he heard that Catra, or someone very much like her, had set the Bone Haven on fire. At first he felt… mental discomfort. He wasn't at all afraid of the Grand Marshal, but he just really didn't want to be in the same place as her, and it had absolutely nothing to do with the fact that she had defeated him during the duel. Besides, she cheated then anyway and this time the outcome of the fight would be completely different. But then he realized that it must have been Lonnie who had hired a shape-shifting creature like Double Trouble to provoke a conflict between the alliance and the Wasteland, it was a brilliant plan! He knew that Lonnie saw him as her most valuable ally and decided to support him.

Now standing before him was one of his officers, a petite Lizardman called Krask , who gave him a soldier's salute, earning a chuckle from the rest of the gang.

“Huntara is heading here with the remaining crew members of that ship. From what I understand, they are looking for Mara's tomb , as a reminder, the previous She-Ra,' she said in an official tone, as if she were a soldier reporting to her superiors.

“I know who Maru was.” he said, although it was the first time he heard this name, he would have remembered it otherwise. “We will set a trap for Huntara and trap her, and then the wasteland will be ours!” he shouted and all his gang members responded with the same shouts. “Almost like I was a member of Thunder Reptiles !”

Eti was feeling bad. She knew she had caused trouble for everyone, especially Bina. She complicated everything because of the anger in her heart. Ever since Icarus, what Moonshadow had done, and the sight of tears in the eyes of that kind Blondie, a Cold Fire had flared up in her soul. She didn't feel much except excitement, power, and anger. Those were stormy days that ended with a terrible outburst of anger in that inn or pub. At first she didn't want to react like that, she just wanted to have fun without Bina's supervision ... But everyone was staring at her and, worst of all, they saw the other one. HER! SHE WAS THERE…she couldn't explain the rage she felt. Then a cold flame erupted and consumed her self. If it weren't for Rosie, she didn't know how it would have ended. However, a cold flame still glowed in her soul . She wasn't sure if this was really the end of the stormy days or if she was just in the eye of the storm.

Rosie… She really liked Rosie. She was so different from everyone she had ever known. She had so much joy in her heart like no one else she had ever met. She may have been deaf... But she saw the world completely differently than all of them. Maybe the rest were just blind and she saw the world as it was? She looked beyond the outer dirt and meanness and saw the inner beauty. And she hurt her, made fear appear in those beautiful blue eyes. It was thanks to her that she understood how wrong she had done. She felt embarrassed, and that happened very rarely. Usually, though, it had to do with Rosie. Why did she care what she thought of her?

“There is something written here.” Rosie said, pointing to a wooden sign embedded in the gravel floor. When they approached she read it. “Land ruled by the Aspis Gang. Everything here belongs to Tung Lashora . Any servant of Huntara or the princesses who comes here will only find a Skull.”

“This reads as death” Itel corrected her with barely concealed impatience.

“But it just says skull. In letters.”

They looked at each other and shrugged.

The Aspis Consortium was the largest, oldest, and most importantly, most ruthless corporation in the known galaxy. They stopped at nothing, from corruption and blackmail, through murder and smuggling, to trafficking in weapons of mass destruction and genocide. But that could just be a coincidence. After all, this planet had been out of the galaxy for centuries or something.

“So what do we do next?” Rosie asked Itel with an uncertain face.

“We can't go back to the Valley, because the guys we pissed off will definitely be there. Perhaps we should warn Bina , then call the ship back and go somewhere else.” Surprisingly, the Elf wasn’t mad at her this time. It was strange and a little disturbing. She understood that it had to do with why she was angry. She couldn't quite name it, but when everyone started looking at her as if she was THAT ONE, she felt furious. Normally, if it weren't for the cold fire, she would somehow control it, but the... She wanted them to stop seeing her as that person, but she also didn't want them to look at her and see who she was. She would love to make everyone blind and gouge out their eyes. Itel would allow it, but not Rosie and Bina... Even though all three of them cared about her.

She looked at the sign and turned to her friends.

“I have a much better idea!” she shouted loudly, and both girls looked at her in surprise.

“What's the idea?” Itel asked skeptically.

“It's simple, my dear itel . I'm pretty sure those guys in that bar are from Huntara and the guys here are her enemies. So I came up with the idea that we would join a gang, and they would welcome us with open arms as a thank you for the brawl we all did together.”

Rosie grimaced.

“You know, I don't think joining a gang is a really good idea, especially one that writes ideograms in letters.” She said, but itel looked like she was considering her words, so she added to convince her.

“These guys definitely know the wasteland, so if there are any ruins somewhere, they'll definitely know where they are.”

That was enough. The elf nodded and said.

“Okay Eti, just please don't do anything stupid. And we will do it discreetly...”

“Just like we always do.” she said and turned on the masking field.

He looked around with binoculars pressed to his eyes and looked for the transport in which the Huntara was supposed to be traveling . He was crouching on a tall red rock. He intended to use the effect dramatically by standing up here, pointing his whip at the vehicle and ordering his gang members below to attack. In his opinion, command was all about drama. The Horde never understood this and that's why they lost. He put down the binoculars and smiled at his own thoughts, admiring his own genius. Then he saw a piece of paper with the word CV in front of his eyes.

“I'm applying to join your gang. This is my CV.” he heard a slightly dull voice coming from the side. At first he started looking through the document, because in the old days his job consisted mainly of reading CVs, but that was in a previous life. He hadn't seen one in twenty-five years. And then he looked to the side and screamed because he saw HER. It was true after all! She was here. And she stood by him. She wore some strange armor and had a rifle on her back, with a scope... sniper one ... and behind her were two girls and. A dark-skinned and green-haired elf hid her face in her hands, and the other, a white-haired one wearing strange glasses, waved at him and smiled serenely.

“Go away! Leave me alone.” he said, retreating in fear, but she did not stop walking towards him. He finally fell over and she climbed up onto his chest with her heavy boots. She was even meaner than last time. She tilted her head and said in a slightly offended voice.

“You know, you could at least read my CV. I irretrievably lost five whole minutes of my life writing them.”

“Why don't you leave me alone?” he said, feeling his voice break.

“Hey, well... Listen, you're Tromlin ! The Azlanti have enslaved your species, and I've been shooting at them quite a bit lately, and Itel has been hitting them pretty hard with her moon sword as well!” she exclaimed, wagging her tail violently. He blinked. Since he got here, no one has called him Tromlin . And she knew about the damn Azlanti. He looked at the girl more closely. He wasn't very familiar with mammalian faces, but she almost certainly looked a bit different. It's because of these eyes. That one had two different colored eyes, and this one's eyes were gold with blue spots. And also this prosthetic hand, strangely made of a single piece of metal. This wasn't Catra... And that meant an opportunity. The company always taught them to be ready to take advantage of every opportunity possible. He slipped out from under the girl's shoes and stood proudly in front of her.

“I'm Tung Lashor. Boss of the Aspis gang. The most feared gang in the Crimson Wastes. Whip!” he said and cracked his whip.

“What he did? I guess my glasses can't describe it.” said the white-haired girl, waving her hands and a voice coming out of her gloves.

“I think he says Whip when he cracks the whip.” the green-haired girl said in disbelief.

- But that's very stupid.” said the white-haired girl.

-“It's like saying blade when I attack with a blade.” added the Elf.

“I can't even make sound of my blows at all.” concluded the white-haired woman.

“Nah” the cat girl interjected. “This could be fun!” she quickly drew her rifle and shot, saying loudly " rifle", at the feet of one of his subordinates, a small and emaciated lizard, who screamed and rolled down the slope.

“Hmmm, this is quite strange. I'd have to shoot again to find out.” the cat girl said in a pensive voice and started aiming again at his gangsters, who started to hide behind the rocks. This was too much.

“Stop pointing guns at my subordinates and tell me what you want from me?” he shouted

The cat girl tilted her head to the side, frowned, and said.

“I said we wanted to join your gang, didn't you hear? Maybe you have hearing problems? It's no shame, my friend can't hear at all, and the punching is so powerful that it breaks jaws and skulls.”

she pointed to the white-haired girl who smiled at him.

“You are my problem! – he roared, and at that moment a laser beam hit the rock. He turned around and saw a large and menacingly painted armored personnel carrier with a cannon operated by a red-haired girl. Before him stood Huntara, a burgundy-haired woman and a true Dragonkin, albeit with multiple cybernetic prosthetics.

“Hey Bina... Whatever you heard, it can all be explained rationally... I don't see any logical reasons for you to be mad at us.” said the cat girl.

She didn't like the way the vehicle was shaking, making noise and... talking. This last one was the worst. He kept talking about

small cars, big bugs and how he didn't like the sun here. So she decided to talk to Lilka. The girl beamed and started her tirade.

“So you're an orc. You must know that it is a huge responsibility. Orcs are noble, courage and brave. And they brush their teeth every day. The latter is the most important. And we orcs travel in the Hordes... “When she frowned, the girl added hastily. “But these are good Hordes, fighting for goodness and justice, not like the nasty Horde of Primus. And when they are victorious, they drink the blood of defeated enemies or hot chocolate. We really like hot chocolate, I have it here.” she handed her a thermos of hot chocolate. Quite tasty. Maybe it wasn't such a bad idea to talk to this girl...

Half an hour later, she felt a growing pain in her head and was glad when they stopped near Aspis' gang territory. They went outside and Bina looked at the datapad .

“So our beloved Eti went there... This could end badly...”

“Tung Lashor rules there, he's a fool and a buffoon, but if your protégé is careful, nothing will happen to her.” she tried to calm down the burgundy-haired woman, but she looked at her and laughed mirthlessly.

“I'm worried about this guy.” she said thoughtfully.

“Wait a minute, I know that name from somewhere.” Alatar said and started looking through his Datapad . It was going to be weird.

They followed the plan... which they improvised when they saw that Tong Lashor, who had been lurking in one of his ambushes, had never understood how they works, was now talking to three girls. Lilka fired a welcome shot from her cannon, and they and the silver-scaled lizard emerged. And then one of Bina's students greeted her... When she saw her, this Eti, she felt that she was making a very strange face. Even from this distance she could see

that she was very similar to Catra... But where did she come from, who was she... and why did she go to that idiot? She sighed and said to Tong Lashor .

“You disgusting reptile, scaly creature, lizard spawn.” she was saying, but then Alatar interrupted her.

“I'm sorry, Mrs. Huntara, but you use very speciesist and offensive terms in your speech to Mr. Lashor. And besides, he's a Tromlin, a member of a race enslaved by the Star Empire, so it's even more offensive.”

And now absolutely everyone turned their eyes towards him.

“You know about Tromlins? And everything?” Tung Lashor asked unexpectedly friendly. His gang members seemed a bit…confused.

“You can also accept Alatar into the Gang, I can handle it somehow.” the cat-like girl muttered, but the Aspis chief didn't seem to pay any attention to her. Alatar nodded.

“Yes, I watched a podcast about your species. Azlanti treated you very cruelly... But I have another question, because is your name related to Tung Lashor from Thunder Reptiles ? That Sidekick Clow Slashor, the leader of the entire team?”

Tung Lashor was outraged.

“He wasn't any Sideck ! He was the most important member of the team and the greatest character in the history of television!” he said with elation, and Bina standing next to her was clearly trying not to laugh

What are they talking about?

“Are you a stupid nerd? Nobody warned me about this! I'm leaving this gang. Rosie, Itel, let's go.” Eti said and slowly started walking towards them, and her companions joined her.

“Well, he's one of the most liked characters.” Alatar replied. “In the new series, they made him Tromlin instead of a lizardman and the adoptive son of Meow -Ru, the villain of the entire franchise. They did it because they wanted to increase diversity of the show. I have it downloaded here on my datapad , but only one season because no more were made. This series was not very popular.”

“Show!” called Tung and, making an acrobatic jump, he moved towards them. His gang members looked embarrassed. She, too, I guess. As the lizard walked towards them, Bina looked at his gang's symbol. She looked surprised, but then a faint, sly smile appeared on her face. Alatar was about to hand over the datapad , but then Bina spoke in a very formal voice.

“It's good that you make sure that the employees you recruit wear the company logo, the management will be happy with it, even if it is not fully consistent with the company dress code”. It is known that the company's policy promotes adaptation to local conditions.

What?

Tung Lashor stiffened, stood up proudly, puffed out his chest, and said.

“Are you from Aspis Consortium?” he asked, shocked and delighted at the same time. She gave a questioning look to the burgundy-haired woman, but she waved her hand, signaling that she would explain everything later.

“Yes, but not officially. The company is interested in entering into Etheria We've been watching you for some time, and I must tell you secretly that some of the board is impressed with your achievements.” she lowered her voice and said in a conspiratorial tone. – Some even say something about the head of the planetary branch.”

In Tung's Lashor’s eyes tears welled up. Tears of pure joy.

“I always knew that the company remembered me. I never doubted it. I have always been loyal to the Consortium.” he said,

his voice breaking. Three girls approached Alatar and started talking to him in whispers, although the white-haired girl spoke in sign language and Lilka was eating a sandwich.

“Yes, we have been wondering for a long time what happened to you. You know well that every employee is important to us.” Bina said in a gentle voice, and he nodded with an expression similar to the one she saw on the clones when they talked about Horde Prime. She felt cold sweat on the back of her neck.

“However, not everyone in the company is favorable to you. Your old rivals within the company are still working against you.” the woman continued, and the lizard gritted its teeth in anger.

“Mondo , you treacherous Skittermader’s piece of carrion. Even after all these years, he still has to give me a hard time.”

“Yes, even the most beautiful tree will have worm-infested fruit. Therefore, everyone came to the conclusion that you need to prove your suitability to the company by completing several tasks assigned by the management.” Bina explained, genuine concern evident in her voice.

“I'll do anything for Consortium . Absolutely everything.” Tung said Lashor, in whose eyes she saw pure devotion. What was wrong with this guy. She had always known him, ever since she came to this wasteland, and even though she thought he was an idiot, he was their idiot.

“Nothing big for now, we are looking for the tomb of a certain Mara, the previous She- Ra, in order to open a theme park related to her, in which the treasures obtained from this tomb will be helpful. For this purpose, I hired a subcontractor, Huntara, who is here, but you will be a key element of our team and thanks to you we will find the tomb. Remember, the whole company is counting on you, won't you let us down?” Bina asked, looking expectantly at Tung Lashor , who saluted the strange burgundy-haired woman and gave her a look of superiority. She wasn't sure whether she should be offended by being called a subcontractor

“Yes, Bina! When can we start?” said the lizard with absolute enthusiasm. Membership jveku .

The gang's mebers looked at each other and whispered, but they seemed to like their leader's new face. This was all getting weirder and weirder.

“Wait, I'll just send my interns back to the ship to Brightmoon” when she said this, both the kids and the white-haired girl gave her offended glances.

The world was becoming far too complicated for someone her age.

Bina watched as the Deadly Sword of Burning Fury landed and the side entrance opened and Miss Daisy and Ireanis stood there. The women were just leaving Mystacor when she called them. Her lovely barbarian band rushed in, greeting the dark sorceress, though Rosie frowned at the dark sorceress, but then shook her head and went inside. Then she herself approached the gloomy woman.

“Listen, Daisy, something came up and I have to stay here and send the kids with you.” she said to her, and Miss Daisy looked at her as if scared.

“I'm not sure if this is a good idea.” Said the gloomy elf uncertainly, but she patted her on the shoulder.

“Don't worry. I believe you will manage. Just don't drink too much.” she said, and the dark sorceress laughed sadly.

“Together with Ireanis, we decided to break the addiction and quit drinking.” Miss Daisy said quietly. She looked at both women. The grim sorceress was holding herself up quite well, but Ireanis's hands were shaking. The silver-haired girl was also smiling stupidly, as if she was hiding some stupid secret. She looked at the two women, patted Miss Daisy on the shoulder again, and

said goodbye to the kids. As she left, she smiled, thinking about the two sorceresses. Everyone deserves love, right?

The sorceress and her apprentice

During the flight, they landed in a clearing located between Brightmoon and the Wastelands. It was already late and they needed to rest, and it had been a difficult day... Day, She guess, because there was no sun here. Anyway, she slept soundly and deeply. She was exhausted, but she still liked be here on Etheria. Even there, in the Wasteland, it was cool. It felt like the climax of a movie or book, when the characters reached the goal of their journey and suddenly it turned out that all the difficulties they had encountered so far were nothing compared to those that awaited them. So far she has been fighting robots, undead and Azlanti.. She met bandits, pirates and princesses. And she found great friends. And Eti.

The morning was strange. Most of the crew and the rest of the people she was used to traveling with were not on the ship, nor were Dilayla, Bina, Lady Cala, or even Dr. Quin. Apart from Mr. Ilemshaw, who had not moved from the ship for obvious reasons, only Wrongdak, Ireanis and Miss Daisy were here. The sad elf looked thoughtful, but at least she wasn't drinking alcohol today, only green tea, just like the silver-haired sorceress. It was probably a good thing, because she was worried about her, but... Then she remembered what the lizard had told her, about a dark sorceress called Shadow Weaver. Only she was from Etheria, and Miss Daisy came from Carurystal. And she came from... She wasn't sure where, but it couldn't be from Etheria... That had been hidden from the world for thousands of years and... And then there was Lady Cala. She was wonderful and brave... They both saved her and Eti. Eti even twice… It couldn't be that terrible woman, could it?

During breakfast she watched her, but tried not to be intrusive, which I guess she didn't quite succeed, because Miss Daisy smiled at her and asked.

“Has something happened, my dear?”

She shook her head hard. It definitely couldn't be her. Such evil people couldn't be nice and smile so warmly... Right?

Wrongdak looked sad, even dejected, so as soon as she ate, she walked up to him and hugged him tightly. Then she pulled away from him and asked.

“Is everything okay with your brother? And at your friend?”

He smiled weakly and replied.

“Yes, everything is fine. They're fine.” he suddenly beamed. “Oh they have a baby, they made them… Together!”

Alatar looked at them and said.

“This is how it's done. Nearly Always” and when Eti looked at him scowling, he added. “I mean, in most cases, and it's not that it's bad when it's different.”

“Don't explain yourself like that anymore, drakey. We all know you're guilty.” said Eti and started eating the kabanos.

Rosie hugged Wrongdak again. He didn't want to tell them what happened, maybe his brother was sick or he had a argument with his friend and now they had quiet days. For all she knew, it could be very stressful, especially when you were friends with both parties. She thought for a moment and looked for Emily. The droid seemed to be as depressed and sullen as the clone. She smiled at her, knelt down next to her and began to speak.

“You know, Emily, you have a lot of new responsibilities waiting for you now.” the three-legged robot turned towards her, staring at her with surprise, so she explained. “Your parents now have another child, so you're kind of an older sister now. You must behave well because you will be a role model for them”

Emily began to look around, surprised, questioningly at everyone. She seemed slightly scared.

"Don't be afraid, Uncle Wrongdak will help you." she said and the clone laughed.

Itel read the maps while the deaf girl talked to the Clone, then went to the navigation room to compare with the data provided by the scanners. Then she looked for Miss Daisy, who, surprisingly, instead of drinking with Ireanis, decided to weigh potions in the workshop. Yesterday's events were... Predictable. Eti was unstable… she knew it from the time she knew her. They were staring at her unnecessarily. No one who knew her do that. But there was something else there. They thought Eti was someone else. She guessed who it was. She had heard references to her more than once during Bina's conversations with Doctor Sidonius. Eti had heard about her too... Itel had never considered the existence of that person... Especially that they would come across her on this planet. She had no idea what to make of it. She knew Eti… She loved Eti, even if she didn't love her back. But who could she be? She saw the fear her friend instilled in the two on the landing pad and in that idiot Tung Lashor. She aroused anger among the guests of that inn, and to Wrongdak she was a friend... It would be difficult for anyone else to understand that one person could combine such opposing traits, but if someone grew up with Eti, they understood it all too well. They had a lot in common, and some crazy twist of fate brought her here. In the place where she went to fulfill her mission. They were supposed to find an artifact for the captain to gain access to Arsenal of the End of Time... But she wasn't sure if she still wanted to work for that person. There was a Starstone here. On Etheria, they had one of the most powerful and... she guess they didn't even know about it, or didn't understand what power was at their fingertips? They could gain importance equal to Absalom Station, being the second center of the galaxy. What other secrets did Etheria hide? They've already met one. They had She-Ra. She saw what she could do. She fought a warship and survived fire from a plasma

cannon, a weapon that should have vaporized an entire city block... And yet she supposedly defeated Horde Prime, the one who was destroying civilizations... Like a Swarm... And she was walking around the fields and meadows like some bored girl from cities. She mourned one child killed by a mad pirate or queen, not fully understanding who Moonshadow really was, while the swarm murdered thousands of children, if not millions, every day. She wanted to tell her that others suffered much more. There are other places in the galaxy where she should use her power instead of signing autographs like some stupid celebrity... No, I don't need her help. The doctor said that there were many artifacts here, perhaps hiding equally great power, and she needed power to achieve her goal, to fulfill her last dream...

Only in this place there was a secret, a small nuance in everything she had experienced. She-Ra, Etheria, the other one... so similar to Eti. There was something in common between them and she had the impression that it all had to do with Eti and her hand... She knows that the Lord Admiral is far from here, and nothing draws him to the "cursed" zone. They had time... But did others have it? The Swarm was still there, they couldn't waste any time.

In the workshop, she stared for a moment at the grim sorceress, who seemed to be more gloomy and lost in thought, wondering whether it was worth starting a conversation with her at all. Apparently she was in Mystacor, from what she understood, it was some kind of magic school or something like that. She always told them that she had once been a respected teacher and might just have found a job there, and now she was worried about how she would tell Lady Cala that she was leaving her. Maybe she was even planning to look for an apartment or study the local curriculum, but Bina interrupted her and told her to look after them. Well, truth be told, Itel didn't care. She didn't like the witch, and Lady Cala was completely indifferent to her. After all, she was a wealthy aristocrat, the world always took care of people like her, while their gang had to take care of themselves. This time, however, she needed the help of the dark sorceress, so she smiled at her and said.

“You know, I was looking through the scans we made on his planet orbit. We have marked several places where there may be important remains of the Star People... The First ones, I mean, and we happen to be close to one of them. I thought we could go there since we're nearby anyway. It's only an hour or an hour and a half away.”

The sorceress looked at her with her emerald green eyes, which held the shadow of something dark. She said slowly, piercing her with her eyes.

“Bina, your guardian and captain, entrusted you to me to watch over you and make sure you don't get into trouble, which, I must mention, happens to you very often. I'm not going to disappoint her, so the answer to your question is No.”

She pursed her lips tightly. This woman dared to forbid them something! The stupid old hag, used to drinking tea from china cups with other useless women, didn't know even a tenth of what they knew about life during their idiotic afternoon teas.

“I didn't ask for your opinion, I'm just informing you about our plans. We are not well-mannered ladies or lords like Lady Cala, who will obediently follow orders because it is the right thing to do. You don't know what we've been through and what we're ready for!” she packed the maps and got up, intending to announce her decision. However, Miss Daisy stood in the aisle. The shadows around her deepened, it felt as if the dark sorceress had filled the entire room.

“I know a lot about young people like you. More than I wanted to know and much more than any decent person should . You want to forget about your pain and suffering, so you take on new and risky ventures. You are angry at the world for what has been done to you and you want to make everyone around you feel the same. But the road you are following leads to destruction...” she said in a sonorous, even thunderous voice.

“You're about to tell us that you were just like us and you know what it's like and that you just don't want us to make the same mistakes.” she asked, smiling mockingly. Miss Daisy laughed bitterly.

“I suffered a lot in my life, but no, I wasn't like you. I created people like you and I don't want to see that again. No one who hasn't experienced what you have experienced will understand how you feel, but don't continue your journey into this darkness. On this planet, you and your friends will finally be able to find happiness, even Eti.”

When she heard her friend's name, she growled and tried to push the woman away.

“If you don't want to help, at least don't bother, just go drink with Ireanis and let us do our thing.”

She felt shadows touch her face. They were cold and sticky, disgusting.

“The old me would have you writhing at my feet begging for mercy.” the entire room was enveloped in darkness, and she felt a twinge of fear, but she only smiled in response and summoned the moonblade. “But I've changed. Since I cannot stop you without resorting to violence, I have no choice but to accompany you on this journey. But know that whatever happens here, it will all be my fault as well as yours.” she stepped aside and let her leave so she could tell her friends.

Rosie looked around with a smile on her face. They were at the edge of a large forest, full of blue trees, their trunks covered with pink gems, and their leaves were various colors, although usually green or blue. Beyond was a plain covered with golden blades of grass and bushes with red leaves. She hadn't felt this so much in the CrimsonWastes, but now she saw that all the colors were more vibrant here, almost pastel. She had the impression that the

air here was filled with power, it made her want to dance. She looked at her friends, who were looking around in confusion. Behind them stood Miss Daisy and Ireanis, who was carrying a backpack so large that it looked like she was going on a multi-day camping trip, not a couple of hours trip... Although they were probably supposed to explore some ruins, and if it was the same here as in that monastery, then it could have been very dangerous there... Good thing she took some ointment for the bites. Wrongdak was left to guard the ship with Emily, although she wasn't sure whether Mr. Ilemshaw alone would be enough to watch over it.

"Where are we now, anyway?" Eti asked, raising and lowering her goggles several times. She was wearing the mask and goggles again, after the events in the bone lair everyone had unanimously decided it would be better for her to hide who she was, and she didn't protest.

"Wait, I'll check on the tourist map." Alatar said, taking out a piece of paper.

"So you bought tourist maps there? What else? That scorpion too?" Eti asked, watching Lilka throw a stuffed scorpion to Toshi.

"No, Scorpia gave him to me. I hope we meet her soon. She was very nice." the redhead explained.

"But we bought a kebab for that while you were setting fire to the inns. It was good...Spicy." he looked pointedly at the cat-like girl, and then added. - Now we are on the border of the Whispering Forest and the Land of Scorpions, I think Centimeni. Our target is in the Valley of Shattered Armor.

When Dragonkin said this, Miss Daisy made a strange, sad face. She felt a surge of suspicion, so to ward him off, she asked.

"Is it still far?"

Alatar shook his head, then looked up from the map.

“No, quite close. Behind this hill with two monuments. Just get past that guy in the robe and we'll be there.” he pointed to a hill visible in the distance, on the top of which there were two obelisks. One was older and half the height of the other, newer one. A man in robes stood between them. He had long hair and a beard, and he held a staff in his hands. She felt Eti pat her on the back with a metal hand.

“Don't worry, he'll definitely like us.”

Everyone always thought that visiting this place would be painful, even traumatic, for him. Perhaps it should be. Here he was finally defeated and captured. Here his former happy life came to an end. But truth be told, he felt much worse in Mystacor, and sometimes even in Brightmoon. He had only one terrible connection with this place, which he didn't remember very well. Besides, compared to the eleven years of existence on the nightmarish Beast Island, these few hours of fighting, when the fate of their world was in the balance, seemed like nothing more than a bad dream. He remembered the hope that burned in his heart. Everyone was so sure of victory then, so radiant with glory... So young. Meanwhile, in Brightmoon, only bitter memories and a cold bed awaited him. Seeing the love in the eyes of Bow and Glimmer, Adora and Catra, and even Scorpia and Perfume, he was reminded of how much he had lost.

He looked at the obelisks, feeling a gentle warm wind blow across his face. The first of them was built here shortly after the battle, with the risk of falling into a trap, because these areas were under the control of the Horde. It had the names of all the Rebel members who died then, including him. He didn't ask for it to be removed, because he had essentially died to the world, and sometimes he felt as if he had never really come back to life. Not fully. The second obelisk was erected shortly after the war. It contains the names of both rebellion members and fallen Horde soldiers. After all, they too were victims. The Horde's losses were well documented thanks to Shadow Weaver's almost obsessive

thoroughness. To anyone else it would be strange that someone so ruthless would record the death of each of his soldiers, but he knew the dark sorceress well from when she was his teacher and knew that a love of order was simply part of her nature. The casualty list on both sides was almost equal. There he saw the names of both Scorpia's mothers who fought for Hordak and her aunt, the rightful ruler of the Scorpions. Perfuma's predecessor was there, Prince Peekablue's husband, Mermista's grandfather... So many... But fortunately, it was all over. The Horde was gone, Shadow Weaver was dead. They could go on living.

Suddenly, his hearing, sensitive from all those years spent on Beast Island, picked up the sound of footsteps. He immediately tightened his grip on his staff and took a fighting stance, ready to fight for his life, but then he heard loud singing.

“In the Whispering Forest, are whispered, things, there is no life and fun, you won't come back from here alive.” the voice was low, a bit dull. He was soon joined by several others and sang in chorus.

“Okay Eti, what's next? I don't think we can end with one line.” the second voice had good diction, but the pronunciation was somewhat similar to that of lizards or other creatures with a lot of fangs. He relaxed, whoever the strangers were, they certainly weren't dangerous

“Well, it will go like this. Anyone who wanders here will soon be hide somewhere. Because there is no smarter than a forester named chester who wanted made your life harder... Okay, I don't know what to sing next” said the first voice again. “ Hey, Grandpa, maybe you have an idea for a sequel.

He turned around with a cheerful smile, which immediately froze on his face when he saw the group coming towards him. The one who sang was a person wearing a mask over his face and goggles, dressed with coat with a hood and a metal hand. There was also a silver-scaled winged lizard with many strange prosthetics like those sold by the people of Icarus, a red-haired

girl with an ax on her shoulder, a green-haired saihe with tattoos of burning roses, and a white-haired girl wearing strange glasses. There was also some fluffy blue creature flying happily around. They gave the impression that they were not afraid to face the most terrible monsters that inhabited Etheria and maybe they could even beat them to the punch. Maybe they weren't so harmless after all.

“Hi... A very strange and somewhat disturbing and, as I hear, quite a joyful group of young people.”

The masked person stretched his tail and said.

“He called us disturbing. This is how you should show respect to the people you meet. An honorable and very kind individual with one foot in the grave, just waiting to his last breath in this miserable vale of tears. If you were... “ she didn't finish because the green-haired woman interrupted her.

“My name is Itel, and the one talking nonsense is Eti. The rest are Lilka Wagardotir, Alatar and Rosie Pearl...” she pointed to her companions one by one. “There are Miss Daisy and Ireanis hanging around somewhere, powerful sorceresses… This flying blue animal is Toshi, our companion. – She pointed to the furry creature that was now trying to bite his sorcerer's staff. “What we do here is entirely our business. We should probably ask what someone like you is doing here, an old man in a wasteland abandoned by devils and demons.”

He smiled because he liked this strange package. He liked such fighting young people, they reminded him of his daughter, Catra and the rest.

“I'm remembering old times. You are almost to the Valley of Shattered Armor. Here, many years ago, the rebellion suffered its greatest defeat. Apart from the loss of the queen..." he said and shook his head to clear away the sudden surge of sadness. “But you're not from here, are you?

The masked girl nodded.”

“You could say so... Or maybe not... It depends on who is asking.

He smiled broadly at her.

“I'm Mikach.” he said and when he saw no reaction, he added. “So you're not from here after all.”

The white-haired woman smiled at him and asked in sign language, and some device translated what she said.

“We're looking for various old things here for research. Because we are interns working for Kemanis University. I can show you the certificate.” she took out a piece of paper that looked correct, although he couldn't confirm its authenticity because he had never heard of it. However, he saw that Saihe looked at the girl called Rossie in surprise. Well, if they wanted to trick him, he would play that game with them. Masked... Eti stepped forward and said in an official tone.

“So, Grandpa, have you seen any ruins here?”

He smiled, shooed Toshi away from his staff so it wouldn't accidentally explode in his teeth, and motioned for them to follow him. The journey took less than fifteen minutes. He also heard, thanks to his sensitive hearing, that two more people were following them. One of them was clumsy and walked as if she was about to fall over, but the other ones were much more attentive. They sounded strangely familiar. Finally they stood over the rocky edge and the expanse of the valley came into view. It was wide and deep. This was the easiest place for the Horde to encircle the Rebel forces, so they decided to set a trap for Hordak's troops here, but instead they fell into a trap set by the Shadow Weaver. She unleashed a terrible spell called the Storm of Bane, which murdered both Rebels and Horde soldiers. She then got rid of many of her rivals, thanks to which she became Hordak's undisputed right-hand man. The effects of the spell were still clearly visible. Everywhere the eye could see, the land of the

valley was scorched with fire and acid. Tank wrecks stood between melted boulders. There used to be soldiers' remains here, but they buried them all after the war. Rosie watched it all with her mouth open, but the others seemed unfazed. They probably came from a planet conquered by Horde Prime, where worse things happened.

“Look not bad, how are the readings going, Alatar.

“It's almost directly below us.” said the lizard and spread its wings and then jumped down.

“Be cautious.” said itel and turned on the engines next to her shoes and flew downstairs.

“Bye, Grandpa.” said Lilka, who lowered herself down the rope attached to the hook. Rosie waved at him and jumped down, falling gently, while Eti ran down the vertical wall.

“But there are stairs there...” he said quietly to himself.

And then he heard a voice he hadn't heard in five years and thought he would never hear again. He felt fury rising in his chest. Without even listening to the words she spoke to him, he turned around and cast a devastating battle spell while raising his magical shield. Shadow Weaver stood there, clad in black, maskless. She deflected the spell, though she recoiled under the pressure of the force. She turned to him again

“Listen to me! Angela….”

“HOW DARE YOU SAY HER NAME!” He roared and hit her with another devastating spell. She blocked them again, but the spell was so strong that her knees buckled beneath her. He was about to cast another spell on her, which this time would wipe out the wicked sorceress from the face of Etheria once and for all. Then she heard a voice casting a spell, and there was a loud bang behind him, and then a stone hand grabbed him tightly, and another hand that grew from his side began to pat his head.

Shadow Weaver looked to the side in surprise. A black Saihe woman with Silver hair stood there, jumping and clapping happily.

“I threw my catching hand and I didn't even faint! I love this planet.”

“I'm impressed Ireanis... Only this other hand...” said the dark sorceress.

“And that's just a side effect.” said Ireanis.

“Finish what you started... It will be an extremely stupid silly death.” he said and laughed bitterly, but he felt tears welling up in his eyes. He won't see his daughter's wedding, they will search for his body, but Shadow Weaver will probably make sure that Glimmer will never know his fate. But instead of killing him, the dark sorceress sighed and spoke slowly.

“Focus and listen to me, instead of letting your anger distract you... Damn, I'm again talking like always.” she rubbed her scarred face. “What I'm trying to tell you is that your wife, Queen Angela, is alive.”

For a moment, he felt inexpressible joy rising in his heart, but he immediately extinguished it.

“You lie as always.” he said firmly. Shadow Weaver closed her yellow eyes.

“I know you have no reason to believe me, but Ireanis saw her too.” she looked at the other woman, who looked surprised and protested.

“But I don't know any Angela”

“Describe Captain Moonshadow.” the dark sorceress asked her companion, who furrowed her silver eyebrows.

“Well, she's tall, she wears a mask, she has wings, only cybernetically aided, and her eyes are this strange, pinkish-purple

color... But what does that matter... Oh! This was your girl, whose heart you had been fighting for years, and she couldn't stand it, so she faked her own...” She didn't finish because Shadow Weaver screamed at her.

“IREANIS! What the fuck are you talking about? I've never been in love with anyone from Etheria. Stop making such ridiculous theories!”

“Okay, okay.” said the silver-haired woman, and the dark sorceress turned to him.

“Ireanis and I have quit drinking since yesterday... could you, my dear, free Mikach?

He felt the stone hands disappear and he stood looking at his former teacher, completely unsure of what he should do now. The essence he had acquired during such a long stay in one of the most terrible places on Etheria told him that he should attack, regardless of what Shadow Weaver said, if he attacked immediately, he would have a chance to kill her before she could react. But if there was even the slightest chance that Angela was alive...

“But how...” he asked after a while. The Dark Sorcerer shook her head and looked at him with a sadness in her eyes that almost seemed sincere.

“I don't know much. She changed a lot. His name is now Captain Moonshadow, and he is the captain of a pirate ship. It strikes terror in the hearts of star travelers.”

He shook his head in disbelief.

“It is impossible. Not my Angela!” he said, feeling his anger returning.

“Suffering can change anyone. Shadow Weaver replied.” I found out that she was a prisoner of the Azlanti Star Empire, it's a terrible fate…” he heard sadness and pain in her voice again. From

a woman who did not hesitate to torment children and murder allies... Another lie. Another manipulation.

“Star Empire? What are you talking about?!” He asked agitatedly.

“You can ask those kids over there, they don't know my identity, but we've been traveling together for a while. They know Captain Moonshadow and if you ask them, they'll tell you all about it.”

Then they heard an explosion and an explosion shook the earth.

“We're talking about a dragon...” Ireanis said, and Shadow Weaver was enveloped in shadows and disappeared.

Heart Gift

Of all the people she planned to visit, it was meeting Mikah that she feared the most. That's why she left it until the end. She suspected she would delay it off as long as possible if she could. However, by a strange twist of fate, she found him in the place of her greatest triumph. And, in a some sense, also greatest failure. The spell she cast here was powerful, even for the inhabitants of the galaxy, although in fact it was very simple, even primitive. Now, with the knowledge she had gained over the five years of learning about the achievements of the Mystics the Galaxy, she would have made them much more effective, or more destructive, and she had not study modern war magic. The cost of casting this spell was great. Her soul was riddled with holes. Power had been leaking from her constantly since the ritual, but now she had to recharge herself with Black Opal every few hours, dooming herself to constantly be near the runestone, as hostage to her own power. But then she also lost what was left of her soul when she banished Mikah to Beast Island. Apart from Adora and Catra, and maybe Scorpia, he was the person she hurt the most, at least out of the ones she knew personally. And now, yes, unexpectedly, she had to face her sin.

She survived, although for a moment she considered letting her former student take out his anger on her, but it wouldn't change anything, or anything would be for the worse. She hasn't won yet, but she hasn't lost either. However, she had to retreat because her second mission, which Bina placed on her shoulders, was calling her. She entered the dark, cold space between the stars and found herself below, shrouded in dust.

“What's the hell you've done?” she shouted and coughed, choking. Bin's wards, and now her wards, peered out from behind the rock and, with the exception of Rosie and, oddly enough, Eti, stared at her with a mixture of amazement and horror. Oh yeah, she forgot to turn on the holographic mask. She reached for the

back of her neck while repeating the question. Rosie answered her

“Sorry, they have earplugs in their ears, I didn't need them, because you know. We... we probably blew up a passage or something.” the deaf girl blushed, and at the same time the others started taking off their earplugs. Itel, of course, crossed her arms over her chest, giving her a defiant look.

“Where did you get the explosives and where did you learn to use them?” she said, but immediately realized that it was completely rhetorical. Eti, however, took a sheet of paper from her coat and handed it to her, and then said.

“We had loads on the ship, but we used them all here.” she said, not even hiding the fact that she was lying. “And here are my permissions.”

She looked at the paper. It was handwritten: "Absolutely Perfect, Awesome and Unique Eti is great at blowing things up and should do it every chance she gets." She didn't even know how to comment on it.

Ireanis appeared nearby using dimension gates, a spell quite popular in the galaxy, and Mikah landed here using a spell that slowed down his fall. He looked at her with surprise. She realized that for the first time in decades, he saw his teacher's face untainted by dark magic. She smiled slightly and touched the face, which shimmered. Then her former student turned to her charges and paled as he realized they were with her. He gave her a look of disbelief. She shrugged. There are still a few surprises waiting for him.

Eti approached him and asked.

“Do these tanks belong to someone, or are they just sitting here?” she asked her former king-consort, who frowned.

“They used to belong to the Horde, but were abandoned there many years during a great battle.” he explained, and Eti clapped

happily.

“So if we get it, no one will blame us. Awesome!” she exclaimed.

Mikach blinked several times and asked.

“Why do you need a tank?

Eti tilted his head to the side and said.

“To drive it and be even scarier than I am, that's absolutely obvious.”

He stared at the girl for a moment, wondering what she meant. He wasn't ready to meet these kids. no one on Etheria wasn't.

“The probability of being attacked by a cat girl in a tank is small, but never zero. “ Dragonkin muttered, and then looked at the rubble. “There was only a false wall there, it was probably movable. Someone must have been search here. I don't know if we'll find anything valuable here, this place was probably robbed of everything valuable a long time ago.” he said sadly. Eti snorted

“You just don't feel like kicking and you're looking for an excuse, drakey.” she said, and Itel added.

“It wouldn't hurt to check... Does grandpa know anything about this place, or will he be as useless as our fairy ladies?”

Mikach almost choked, not out of outrage. Even when she was a teacher in Mystacor no one would dare call her useless, and said.

“It was the border of scorpion country. It would be difficult to know the truth now...”

“Maybe when Mrs. Scorpia comes back with Mrs. Perfuma, we will ask them?” Lilka asked.

“Do you know Princess Scorpia and Perfuma?” Mikach asked, surprised.

Yeah, we met Sting and Vegie on Icarus . There was also a Blondie who grows and turns into a BLONDE, but Captain Wingy attacked her and wanted to kill her along with half the town. I don't know what happened to her, but it's a real shame because they were both so cool.” Eti explained to him. It took him a long time to decipher the words

“Captain Wingy?” asked the former king-consort. His face showed both hope and fear. Rosie nodded and said.

“That's how Eti calls Captain Moonshadow. She's the kind of pirate who's been with us since we left Saltmarsh, that dusty planet, whatever. She's a bit scary and if you serve the Azlanti she'll kill you cruelly, but she's not that bad. She helped us in this monastery and was quite nice to us. She said I reminded her of her daughter, whom she lost a long time ago and she had a husband, but she also lost him.”

Pain appeared in Mikah's eyes. Barely holding back his tears, he asked.

“And… how that Moonshadow looked like.” when he saw Itel's suspicious look, he added.” I've never seen a space pirate and I'm curious what she looks like.” he explained, smiling weakly. Rosie nodded in understanding, though the others seemed unconvinced , and began to explain to him.

“She is very tall and has pink-purple hair and these strange translucent wings, but they were probably damaged and now she has to cybernetically support them. She also lost her right arm and has a cybernetic limb instead. And he wears a mask made of this crystal, although I'm not sure if he's hiding some terrible scars under it or if he just thinks it looks cool. And she's a Solarian like Itel, only she summons a flare instead of a blade.” she explained, and Itel bit her lip in irritation. Mikah looked shocked and terrified, which didn't go unnoticed by the green-haired Elf, who began to look at him with even greater distrust.

“And what happened to her? Why did she fight Adora?” Rosie asked, clearly confused.

“I'm not sure, Adora called her Angela and Queen, but I don't know why. Moonshadow got mad at her and they started fighting... She wanted to take her to the ship to the Gardens of the Long Death because she claimed that Adora had taken her sword, but she claimed that it was broken. Adora isn't one to lie like that, but she wanted to imprison her anyway... These gardens... I don't know what they are, but they're scary. There he locks up the captured Azlanti officers and this terrifies them.”

Mikah stepped back and wiped his forehead. He tried to sort out what he had learned, but it wasn't easy... She knew something about it herself. Well, his peaceful days on Etheria are over. Though considering he was here and not in Brightmoon , the old demons were still chasing him... Even the ones he thought had abandoned him forever.

“Are you okay?’ Rosie asked with concern in her voice and approached Mikah . Eti stood next to him and looked at him.

"I'm fine..." the former king-consort shook his head. And he smiled friendly, trying to hide how much their story shocked him.” Your story just seemed so scary and all. These pirates and Azlanti... You don't see such things here.” he explained , and Rosie nodded understandingly, but Itel quietly snorted with contempt and then turned to everyone.

“Maybe instead of talking about bullshit, we should start digging up these ruins? And you, Grandpasince you've already listened to an interesting story, maybe you'll do some hermit things and go away.”

“No... I'll help you... I know a little about the remains of the First Ones.” her former student replied and she added.

“Ireanis and I will also help.”

Itel clenched her jaw angrily, but she didn't say anything and just got to work.

She was ashamed to admit that her physical condition left much to be desired. Due to the fact that she was an elf , or Saihe as they called they here , she was biologically at least ten years younger than Mikah, but he worked at least twice as efficiently. What a blow to her perfectionist soul . Even Ireanis was more useful because she used magic to lift stones. She also looked at Mikah with interest, but it didn't refer to their earlier conversation. As she stood aside to stretch her back a bit, Itel came up to her and spoke sharply in a low voice.

“Watch out for this guy, you're supposed to keep an eye on him. I don't like him even more than you do. I suspect it's some Azlanti corsair who's been hiding out for the last five years.”

She blinked twice at the girl's theory.

“And on what basis did you draw this conclusion?” she asked, hiding her amusement. The Solarian rolled her eyes as if she had to explain something obvious and began to explain.

“Did you see how scared he looked when that deaf girl talked about Captain Moonshadow? He's afraid of her! And besides, he doesn't talk like a forest grandfather. You are an elf and you certainly won't side with such a speciesist

“I'll keep an eye on him, but this 'Deaf Girl's” name is Rosie.” she said, staring at the Elf, who clenched her fists angrily

“What do you mean?” she growled

“Rejection is painful, I have seen with my own eyes what things those affected by it can do.”

Itel looked at her feet and asked.

“Will it ever stop hurting?”

“ I'm not an expert in this type of matters, but I can tell you one thing. The pain will ease as you allow this wound to heal.”

Itel smiled sourly

W”as this the advice you gave to Lady Cala?

“Lady Cala is not someone who needs advice on this type of thing.”

The elf waved her hand and went back to work.

At the end of the work, when the passage to the interior of the ruins was almost visible, she and Mikah took a break, taking advantage of the opportunity that her charges were busy discussing what they should do. they moved aside so that they would not be heard.

“What does it mean? What happened to Angela ? Why did she want to kill Adora ? Is this your doing?” asked her former student, barely containing his outburst of fury

She sighed. It shouldn't surprise her that no one trusts her and that everyone blames her for their misfortunes. She tried very hard to make it happen. Still, against her better judgment, it hurt her. *Now I know how you felt, Catra, when everyone, except Adora of course, blamed you.*

“I already told you that I don't know much, and don't attribute other people's faults to me, I have more than enough of my own sins.” she said slowly and Mikah looked at her judgmentally and said.

“Indeed, more than enough.”

She ignored the insult and continued explaining.

“It seems to me that she has lost most of her memory, and what is left is distorted in some way. Anyway, she didn't recognize me or Eti...”

“Why would she recognize her?” Mikach interrupted her. – She's not from Etheri, how could she know her?

She smiled and said.

“You'll understand as soon as you see her. Just don't stare at her. Then he gets angry.”

“What do you mean by Gets angry?” he asked, looking at her suspiciously.

“She burned down the Bone Haven yesterday because some customers were staring at her. She can be unpredictable, but she's a good, hurt girl.” she explained to her former student, who smiled crookedly and said in an accusatory tone...

“Just like Catra.”

“Yes, just like Catra.”

It was downright painful to be around this vile woman and pretend they didn't know each other, smiling and being gently and polite. Only with the greatest effort of will did he manage to control his fury. He only did it for Angela's sake. If there was even the slightest chance that he could get her back, that they would be together again, he was willing to make almost any sacrifice.

It didn't help that she was now back to the face she had when she was still a Light Spinner. The sight of his former teacher, who was closer to him than his birth mother, whom he lost in childhood, unnerved him. He wasn't sure if it was out of vanity or shame that she chose to hide her true nature, but it made him despise her even more. She seemed more composed and nicer than he remembered her, but he knew very well that she could be very polite, even charming, when it was in her best interest. Glimmer learned this very well, too.

He couldn't understand what kind of madman had allowed her to take care of kids again. Oddly enough, these young people didn't seem intimidated by the dark sorceress. In fact, with the exception of that deaf girl, Rosie, they didn't hold her in high esteem, and this Saihe named Itel treated her with downright contempt. This didn't match the image of Shadow Weaver that Catra, Adora, and Scorpia painted before him. And the one he remembered: "It 's all a game, a pretense intended to deceive others. Manipulate them into doing what she wanted them to do. I won't be fooled again."

Finally, they managed to clear the passage and saw a wide corridor made of blue crystal. A shiver ran through him.

“I don't know if you should explore these ruins. The other were very dangerous and had dark motives.” he warned his young companions.

“Wow, they were almost like me. Almost, because there is no creature more dangerous than me, although on this planet they don't know it yet. But its only matter of time.” Eti said, but Rosie frowned and asked.

“But we met Adora . She was very nice.” she looked at him expectantly. He sighed and explained.

“Adora was raised in the Fright Zone and knows nothing about her people, we all know very little about the First Ones, apart from the fact that their technology was extremely advanced... There were only three people who might have known anything more about them, but two of them they are dead, and the last one is quite difficult to communicate with. And that's good, maybe it's better if everything they left behind is forgotten.”

Rosie thought for a moment and said.

“The First ones department on Kemanis University and the entire Anacite species would disagree with you.”

He blinked in surprise and asked

“So you know about the First Ones?”

The girl nodded and wanted to say something, but Itel interrupted her.

“Don't waste your time on pointless chats. Let's go!”

The corridor was wide, but quite low, so Shadow Weaver and Alatar had to hunch over. They could only walk comfortably in pairs. Eti and Rosie led the way, followed by Itel and Lilka, then Ireanis and Alatar, and he had to go last with Shadow Weaver. He had the impression that he, Itel, and Alatar were equally dissatisfied with their couple. It was dim here, as the walls emanated with a faint glow. They were covered with numerous inscriptions in the language of the First Ones, which the red-haired girl meticulously wrote down. It was amazingly clean here. He heard from Adora that her people's structures were capable of self-cleaning and self-repairing . It must have been similar here, which meant that the building was functioning. This means that the defense systems were most likely also active. They had to be careful.

Walking side by side next to Shadow Weaver was not a pleasant experience. He tried to ignore her, but it was hard, even if she didn't speak to him or look his way. He sensed its dark power even without using his magical senses. He could actually feel the bittersweet taste of darkness on his tongue, flowing from the dark sorceress's soul. Perhaps it was just the power of suggestion... Or maybe it was because he was forced to use dark magic while he was chipped . He had almost forgotten about it, but he was aware that the taint of the dark art could never be eradicated, even if one was forced to use it. This was the epitome of Horde Prime's perfidy . Now perhaps there was simply an affinity between them, as perhaps among all who had been tainted by a dark power. The thought of having anything to do with someone so vile made him feel sick.

“In front of us is a large room with a closed door.” Eti exclaimed.

Sure enough, they finally found themselves in a huge chamber with a tall, pulsating pillar in the center. There were many more inscriptions, they covered the entire walls with a dense web. There was also a stained glass window, like all the art of the First Ones, beautiful in its simplicity. It depicted two women. One of them was a warrior whom he recognized as She-Ra, probably Mara, and the other was a tall woman in robes. He guessed who she was. Light Hope. They touched each other with their fingertips , from which light flowed, which twisted in a spiral and finally merged, transforming into another figure, a petite girl emanating her own glow.

“This one is probably a BLONDE, but different one and the other one is probably her girlfriend. And the third one is probably their child or something.” Eti said, and Rosie added, smiling with delight.

“I think they look very romantic, don't you think?”

Itel scowled at her and said.

“We didn't come here to see beautiful views. Grandpa, do you know what this is about?”

He thought for a moment about what answer he should give them and finally said it.

“You're right Eti, this is the previous She-Ra. Her name was Mara and she was a great heroine. The other one is Light Hope. She was the artificial intelligence who oversaw the planetary facility.”

Rosie tilted her head to the side and stated.

“If they loved each other, it's offensive to call her artificial intelligence. It should be called digital consciousness... I wonder how they did it, you know, child? I've read about similar couples and...” she didn't finish because itel silenced her with a wave of her hand.

“Where can I find this Light Hope ? I have to talk to her!” Saihe will shout . He shook his head sadly

“Unfortunately... or fortunately, this is no longer possible.”

The elf wanted to lash out him, but Eti said yes.

“Maybe there's something cool inside. Lilka, Alatar, take out the… archaeological tools and I will listen to what is on the other side.” she was near them in one bound and took out her stethoscope. During this time, Alatar will take out a pickaxe from his backpack and Lilka will take out a blowtorch.

“What are you going to do about it?” he shouted, but Eti signaled him to be quiet and uncovered her face. He inhaled sharply, but refrained from exclaiming astonishment. The girl who was kneeling by the door looked like Catra... No... They were different from each other. She had sharper facial features and straight, dark red hair, and her eyes were gold with many blue spots. They were like... sisters.

He looked away, remembering Shadow Weaver's warning. Now he understood the dark sorceress's comment about Angela not recognizing Eti. His wife had never faced Catra, but she knew what she looked like. Neither Eti nor Shadow Weaver made her remember anything. She only recognized Adora ... Why?

And then Rosie touched the pillar and bright lights flashed.

Rosie was glad that they were able to find new friends even in such a remote place, especially after the unfortunate events in the desert. Mikah was like one of those great sages of the forest who seek out heroes before a great mission and share enigmatic advice with him. Only Mikch wasn't enough... crazy and inscrutable. In fact, he seemed like some mystical fallen order knight hiding in exile. Only the people of Etheria didn't look like they would banish others, maybe this Tung Lashor looked like one, but he wasn't from Etheria, and he was a fool.

Itel didn't trust Mikah , but she didn't trust anyone. But he looked wise, and as she looked at him, she hoped he might be able to explain to her what was happening to her. Rosie had felt a bit like she had been in a dream since she entered those dungeons. As she looked at the writings on the walls, they seemed familiar. As if she had seen them before but had no idea what they meant. They were different from the ones she remembered, as if they were two different, yet related languages. She had the impression that their meaning was inaccessible to her, as if the very attempt to understand them was beyond her reach, something forbidden by nature itself.

And then there was the buzzing. She could sense loud sounds because they made the air vibrate, but there was something else. It existed in her head. It was almost like music, or at least as she imagined it. It was surprisingly pleasant, and it gladdened her heart. But somehow it lulled her to sleep, made her feel almost drugged. This place also seemed familiar, as if she had read and seen about them in books or other sources before. She felt as if she had arrived at her grandparents' house, which her parents had told her about.

And then she stood at the pillar. As she approached the pillar, the buzzing became stronger, Itel was curious about this Light Hope , because she seemed to want to learn more about Etheri from her, but she was more interested in the third figure. She was curious who she was, even Mikah didn't seem to recognize her. Driven by a sudden impulse, she touched a fragment of a painting depicting a child. And then the lights flashed.

“What have you did, you stupid! - Itel jumped at her with fury on her face.

“I don't know... I just touched this pillar... I didn't want to do anything.” she said to the elf, asking her for forgiveness with her eyes, but she looked as if she wanted to scream or maybe even hit her, but Eti silenced her with her eyes. And then a blue, translucent figure appeared among them. She looked like a girl about her age, with short hair tied in a bun. She wore formal, if

rather old-fashioned, attire, looking like a combination of a scientist's uniform and priest's robes. She smiled at them in a friendly manner, with shy curiosity.

“Hello, how can I serve?” she asked.

“GHOST!” Ireanis shouted. “Away, you impure force!” she cast a spell that looked like shimmering silver dust. The translucent person laughed and said.

“Ghosts don’t exist and even if there were, they wouldn't be me. I am Heart Gift, a Planetary Archive, I use the pronouns she, her. I am... I AM.” she said, looking at her hand in amazement. Suddenly she started disappearing and reappearing in different places, shouting joyfully, "I am!" She finally appeared in the center of the room in a summer dress with longer flowing hair.

“I am! Isn't it wonderful!” She whirled happily. Rosie smiled at her friendly and said.

“Hello Heart Gift . It's good that you enjoy your existence. I'm Rosie Pearl and these are my friends. – she pointed to the others who introduced themselves, except for Itel, who crossed her arms over her chest, looking at their guest, or rather host, with a fierce expression. Miss Daisy and Mikah eyed Heart Gift as if she were a dangerous beast, but quietly introduced themselves to her.

“Hello. You are in one of my many terminals. My duty was to archive the data collected by Light Hope and Mara. Actually, we talked a lot. They told me about many things. They adventures and research….”

Rosie looked at the image on the pillar and beamed.

“You are that child. Mara and Light Hope are your moms!” she said happily, and Heart Gift teleported to her.

“My moms?” she asked in surprise, thought and then clapped happily. “Yes! They are my mothers.” Miniature fireworks began to go off around Heart Gift . “It's so wonderful! I never thought of

them that way, but it must be true. Do you think they know about it? Oh, of course they know that, I'm so silly sometimes. They simply didn't tell me about it because they waited for me to figure it out on my own. Until I'm mature enough to understand it! I need to tell them about this." She looked around and teleported around the room again, this time calling out " Light Hope!" She finally stopped and frowned. “She can't hear me... She probably went to sleep... I used to sleep for a long time, but I just woke up recently. I haven't seen Mara for a long time either... She must be on some distant journey... But she'll be back soon. And then the three of us will celebrate Mother's and Children's Day together. This will be so wonderful!” Heart Gift turned into three rainbow streaks of light. Dancing in a spiral. No one shared her joy. Everyone watched her with sadness and confusion. She could see pain in Mikah's eyes. At first she didn't understand what they were worrying about, until she remembered that Bina was looking for Mara's Tomb, and the old man was talking about Light Hope in the past tense, as if she... Oh no... Now tears came to Rosie's eyes. She was glad that her eyes weren't visible through her glasses, but even so, when Heart Gift turned away from her, she discreetly rubbed her eyes. She felt so much sadness, but she didn't have the courage to tell Heart Gift the truth. She felt ashamed about it. The digital consciousness stopped and looked at her, then clutched her face as if she had just remembered something.

“Oh my matrix, I think I completely forgot about you. What a host I am!” she laughed shyly and asked. “How can I help you? Do you have any questions for me? I'm sure I can answer them. I have access to all the knowledge stored in my archive, which means I practically know what my Mother knew... Light Hope.”

“What is Etheria's greatest treasure?” Itel asked suddenly, although Miss Daisy glared at her. Heart Gift appeared right in front of the Elf and said.

“It's the Heart of Etheria, of course. One of the greatest projects carried out by the First Ones, right next to the Will of Unity, Blood of Xadia and Shroud Projects.” she explained. “Although I have only sketchy information about the others.

“So tell me about it, Heart...” Itel asked, not paying attention to Mikah, who was telling her to be silent.

“Oh, I can tell you about it…” she started rubbing the dirt under her embarrassment. “I'd just have to ask for permission my mom Light Hope. I'll look for her and...”

“There is no need.” Miss Daisy said, ignoring the angry look the Solarian woman gave her. “We have to go back now. It was very nice to meet you, Heart Gift. “The woman smiled at the digital consciousness. Heart Gift looked at them with sudden fear.”

“But... Will you visit me again? I've been lonely for a very long time and I don't want that to happen again... Please.”

Miss Daisy looked at Heart Gift as if she was wondering about something, and then asked.

“Could you show us a map of your terminals?”

Heart Gift nodded and waved her hand, and a map of Etheri appeared with terminals marked on it. When Alatar touched it, it turned out to be fully interactive and Dragonkin could see all the points. At this time, Heart Gift appeared in front of Eti.

“You know, I think I saw someone like you recently.”

“You must have Imagined it. There is no one like me.”

She learned some new things, and they weren't exactly uplifting things. She didn't know Light Hope, and that was good, because everything would have ended much worse for everyone, literally everyone. Now it turned out that she and Mara had a child, that AI the Heart Gift, there was no doubt about it... Only Etheria was transformed to the core into one great experiment, a device on a planetary scale. It is unknown what other secrets of her home world the Light Hope child had access to. She seemed to be more spontaneous than her mother, more emotional, at least as far as

she could tell from the few words Adora had said that she had managed to overhear. What powers could this creature have? Even if she didn't have access to all of Light Hope's capabilities, as a planetary archive it had access to knowledge that in the hands of someone nefarious could lead to disaster, and her true ward was most likely the nefarious person on the planet.

Xadia was also mentioned. She first heard it from the mouth of Aaravos , a mysterious sorcerer she met in the mirror, the same one Castaspella found. She had already sensed the darkness emanating from him, and that was why she didn't trust him. She refused to perform a ritual that would keep them in constant contact, but that didn't stop her from listening to him and becoming interested in the ritual that turned her into the creature that ruined the lives of so many. Now she wondered if her own darkness had surpassed that of this creature. Once, after she had settled on Carurystal, she tried to find out what species the creature belonged to, but it was completely unknown in the Galaxy. Aaravos seemed to be connected to the First Ones, and she was now almost certain that he was a servant of the Creeping Chaos

Once they were outside, her charges, it was disturbing how quickly she started calling them that in her mind, they started climbing the mountain, though Itel was still furious with her, she stopped to talk to Mikah again. As soon as the young crew members were far enough away, her former apprentice growled at her.

"You missed tormenting Catra so much that you had to find another victim?!"

I wonder what you would say if you saw Lady Cala? she thought and said.

"I never hurt Eti, I even saved her life twice, although I know she suffered a lot. However, I am not responsible for this..."

“Who is she anyway?! Why is she so like her?” exclaimed the former king-consort. He was still furious, he probably didn't believe her. He had the right to do so.

“I know it was created almost six years ago by a man named Jantar on a Planet called Atrax. He also created Catra twenty-three years ago. There's much more I can't tell you. “she explained, looking her former student straight in the eyes. Mikah looked surprised, but not as surprised as she might have expected.

“Catra seems to be starting to get suspicious. Lately she keeps checking old cadet documents…. Did you know about it? he looked at her sharply. She shook her head.

“I never suspected anything. I have always been too overconfident to question my own judgments…”

He nodded and said.

“You've always been arrogant, even as a Light Spinner ... What exactly do you want from me, apart from telling me about the tragedy that happened to my wife and insulting all those you hurt just by being alive?” Mikah's voice was as sharp as Veska's executioner's axe

“First of all, I want to meet with you and some of my other allies during the Victory Day celebrations to discuss some pressing issues.” she sighed and continued. “The galaxy is vast and full of threats that are reaching out to Etheria in their clutches. One of them is the Azlanti Star Empire. The same one that hurt Angela so much that she became Captain Moonshadow. It is a powerful empire that believes in the supremacy of the human species, your species. Everyone else, called Inhumans, are second-class citizens at best, only if they put up resistance, of course. If the Azlanti came here, Scorpia, Catra, all my people, would be deprived of most of their rights, and your daughter, as a hideous half-breed, will be lucky to spare alive. And Azlanti is nearby. That's why I'm asking you to talk discreetly with my other allies and keep the

knowledge that I live for youself, at least for a few days”- she explained, trying to sound as sincere as possible.

Mikah thought for a moment, then laughed with heartbreaking bitterness.

“You know, everything that happened to my wife should happen to you. Angela… someone like you can't understand what a wonderful person she was. She personified nobility, integrity and goodness. Do you know that before she sacrificed herself, she told Adora that she was a coward? But the biggest coward has always been you. You did everything just to survive. Sacrifice everyone and everything.” as he spoke, contempt burned in his eyes. She did not protest against the former student's accusations, because he was right. “I will do what you ask me, but only because today I also turned out to be a coward, because I did not have the courage to say Hear Gift about her mothers death.”

Tomb

“My name is Tung Lashor, I am not afraid of you, Meow-ru . No more. Whip!” came from the side of the Datapad that Tung Lasshor was holding and showing his subordinates a cartoon featuring the character he was based on. In her opinion, the series was quite stupid and belated propaganda, which was published after the end of the Cold War between Veskarium and the Pact Worlds. The main villains were vampiric Pahtra who laughed while making "Meow meow meow meow" and the dim-witted Veskarian general Gerok , who, for some inexplicable reason, commanded mostly the Skittermaders. There were, of course, nice, if terribly inept, Pahtra villagers even among the Thunder Reptiles was one Vesk, a technomancer named Egrux. Apparently the original version takes place on the lost Golarion and instead of Skittermanders there were Goblins, but she hasn't seen a single part of the Original Series. However, the new series was liked by all Aspis gang members, who cheered when Tung Lashor appeared on the screen and hissed when they saw Meow-ru . Surprisingly, the fact that he based himself on a character from the series only made his subordinates respect him even more. It was as cute as it was stupid. Huntara, sitting next to her, looked at her old enemy with emptiness in her eyes. Some truths are better left unknowing...

They were driving Crusher into the desert with Tung Lashor and his most devoted subordinates. What disturbed her companion more than her former rival's presence was that he had begun to treat her with the typical for office workers passive aggression, instead of the hostility she was accustomed to. Well, the wide universe had its dark and annoying sides.

The tomb was located among rocky hills. They were thickly covered with thorn bushes with thorns as sharp as steel razors. At

first they tried to make their way on board the Crusher, but she decided there was too much risk of puncturing the tires, so they continued to make their way on foot. They did this surprisingly well, but the bigger problem was the iron-beaked, three-eyed birds and the three-headed snakes that fed on them. The latter reportedly grew up to ten meters in length. When they had around two meters, they left the dense bush and hunted almost everything. Fortunately, they were not poisonous and only bit one of Tung's subordinates. It was fortunate that her wards weren't here, or the Etherians would have learned a new word, "uncontrolled bushfires."

When they reached the site where the tomb was supposed to be, they set up camp. Then Tung arranged to watch the series together with his companions, and she and Huntara drank Ashrak , a green, slightly sour drink made from the leaves of a bacterivorous shrub growing in the caves of Atrax . It was refreshing and stimulating at the same time. She was going to sell it on Victory Day. She'll make some money out of it, and above all, they'll have a great cover. She bought it on Saltmarsh for this very purpose, although she did not expect that she would sell it on Etheria, but who could have guessed that it would not be a place cursed by devils and demons, a place of evil. She even had to admit that you liked the planet, even the damn wasteland. Maybe if the locals like this drink, then maybe they will settle here with their kids and open Ashrak drinking houses? It won't be difficult to bring it here since she already knows how to get here. She will then be a pioneer, the first businesswoman from outside the empire who will open her own business here.

In the evening, she invited Huntara into her sleeping bag. She wasn't exactly her type, but she had to admit she was experienced. They spent some nice moments together, more than a few. Tung's Lashor’s subordinates didn't notice anything. She suspected they wouldn't even notice that someone was trying to steal them. They got up early before everyone else, it turned out that the leader of the Aspis liked to sleep in. Well, you can see that his corporate culture has disappeared in this aspect. They took their time and prepared breakfast, very relaxed.

“These kids... they're not yours.” Huntara asked and grimaced, understanding what she said and explained. “I know you're not their mother, because neither their age nor their... species match. Only... they look like you were choosing them one from… different realms, like a chef who buys different pieces of meat to make a pie... Damn, that sounded bad. I mean, they're so different. From themselves and from you.”

She smiled and started telling the story to the woman sitting next to her.

“Alatar comes from a middle-income family from the suburbs. Lilka was born on a farm, and Itel grew up in a small settlement in the forest...”

“And this cat-like... Eti.” asked the Princess of the Crimson Wastes. She smiled sadly and after some thought, she said.

“Eti... she is a mystery in itself. She was very hurt. I guess your Catra too.” She asked and looked questioningly at the warrior. Huntara frowned.

“All of us in the Horde lived in one big barracks with a factory added to it. But if it was hard for us, for Catra it was... She, just like Adora and the rest, was a Cadet. An orphan who was supposed to become the perfect Horde soldier. She was trained for military service from childhood. They were treated brutally there, they didn't know many normal things like holidays, family and stuff like that. They were only taught fighting and loyalty, and everything was managed by this dark bitch.

“Ah, that sounds so familiar...” Bina said in a thoughtful voice. “Eti and I... we were all brought up similarly. You see, we, thousand sisters, are clones of our father, kind of like Horde Prime's clones. I was created eleven years ago.”

“What?” Huntara asked with horror. Hearing what she rolled her eyes.

“Don't worry, I'm a thirty-year-old woman, mentally and physically, although with my kids I feel like I'm sixty. Tell me about this dark bitch, how you described her so nicely.” she took another sip of Ashrak, but it was good in the morning. Huntara shrugged uncertainly and said.

“Her name was Shadow Weaver. I didn't know her well. She was a powerful sorceress, the mistress of shadows. She commanded the entire Horde as Hordak's right-hand woman. She was mean to everyone, but to Catra... I don't know much about it. I don't know this girl that well, just like that hag. She always held Catra close as if she was her right hand, her acolyte. But she was treat like the dirt, tormented and humiliated. Catra overthrew her, and Shadow Weaver sought refuge in Brightmoon. The last time I saw her was at Glimmer's coronation. Her damn mask was cracked, but she was still ashamed to show her ugly face. Dark spells apparently twisted her like that. She used to be a teacher in Mystacor, but she messed up some terrible magic. She used to be a Saihe like your Itel, but then she became a monster, with a scarred mouth, fangs and claws. She was still damn pretty powerful. In the Fright Zone she was always surrounded by darkness, but in Brightmoon she acted like a fucking lady. Fuck, it's a good thing that bitch died . - Huntara said and spat Ashrak - green saliva.

“Yeah. It is good” she said quietly, feeling shivers of anxiety. The description reminded me of Miss Daisy, only she wasn't corrupted by dark magic and, above all, she was alive. But for the rest of the meal, she couldn't shake the ominous feeling. When Tung Lashor finally began to slowly wake up, Huntara asked in a low voice.

“What's going on with this Aspis? What is this?”

Bina sighed, it wasn't easy to explain to someone from a planet like this, but she had to try.

“it's like a Trade Houseor a guild, only larger, with its influence covering the entire galaxy. They trade in everything, absolutely everything, even weapons of mass destruction and sentient

beings, if it is profitable for them and is at least theoretically legal.” Seeing Huntara's shocked look, she added, smiling sadly. “The galaxy has its dark sides. And Aspis is one of the darkest. They are willing to do anything for profit if they can get away with it, even murdering an entire colony or selling out its inhabitants. Employees are constantly indoctrinated and often groomed from childhood. They only buy the company's products and only marry their co-workers. And when they want to change jobs, they are burdened with such debts that they will not get out of them for three generations, unless they return on their knees, then they will be accepted, but they will have to start everything from the lowest rung. Tung Lashor’s was probably someone like that was probably something like that, and apart from the indoctrination, he had always been a fool. Well, these people either die first or become leaders. This probably doesn't reflect well on society. There is also this Azlanti thread, but more about these bastards another time...”

Huntra may have been the toughest warrior on Etheri, but even she wasn't ready to face the horrors of galactization.

“Do you…”

She waved her hand.

“Come on. I served a deranged, tyrannical father, who was no better than Horde Prime, but I'd rather die than work for those scum... I have principles.”

Tough warrior spat and said

“I hope they never reach Etheria.” Said the Princess of the Crimson Wastes, but she smiled half-heartedly. She showed the portable stove, a tube of sharp paste, her weapon and even her shoes.

“Too late. It was all produced by Aspis Consortium. They are already here.”

Huntara looked at her with horror.

She read the pieces maps and looked around the shallow basin. In its center there was a rainbow-colored steaming pool from which a surprisingly pleasant scent emanated. She knew enough of the Wasteland to know it was a bad omen, so she wrapped a rag around her face, as did most of the Tung Lashor gang. And Bina put on a helmet to protect her from all poisons and miasmas. They did the right thing, because when it turned out that one of the gang members, a hyenoman called Bob with a mane of dyed green hair, did not wear any protection and fell to the ground and started rolling, howling in terror. He shouted about a winged warrior with a fiery sword. It sounded strange, a bit sily, but Bina and Tung looked at each other worriedly.

"Okay, so what do we do?" she asked, looking at the others. Bina saluted and said.

"Fortunately, I have a certain magical item... Alatar told me to buy it because i was afraid of fiery and hot things. For example, Eti grenades, solarian explosions, flaming axes, Alatar's fire breath, and endless flaming mistakes of Ireanis. It will come in handy here too."

She sprayed herself with a red substance and jumped into the water. Only Tung wasn't surprised by what she did. They waited for several long moments until the ground around them shook and an island, Bina in armor, began to emerge from the lake and waved at them.

"There was a lever there, you just had to move it." said the interplanetary traveler in a satisfied voice. There was a narrow stone bridge running from the islet to the shore, and in the middle there was a not very high stone building. Perhaps it was a tomb, although rather small. She had heard that the scorpion lords built huge burial mounds out of earth, and on the Sorrow Islands, each clan had its own necropolis where all its worthy members were buried. She had no idea who the people who buried Mara were, but they obviously had plenty of time and resources to build such

a tomb. The woman there was supposedly a hero who sacrificed herself to save them all or something like that. Maybe they wanted to show gratitude for her sacrifice, or were they her friends who wanted to honor her memory in this way? The kablotka, a representative of this strange people who worship dragons or something, went ahead and checked whether there were any traps along the way, and Tung and Bina did it again. Then they started looking at the door. They did this for a good quarter of an hour until she was sweating all over from standing by the boiling lake, so she simply pushed them away, irritated and open doors. Then Tung and Bina looked at her like she was crazy.

“Traps, curses...” said the Aspis leader.

“Undead, imprisoned devils...” added Bina.

“What devils?” she asked, not knowing what they were talking about.

“Manager, they don't know much about this type of thing. I've only seen one imp so far, and he was a fake one.” the head of the Aspis explained to the travelers.

“Is everyone in the galaxy this paranoid? It's just a damn tomb”

They looked at her in a way that made her feel young. Like a rookie on his first expedition.

“You know, if this Mara was someone like Adora, we shouldn't have encountered the undead, but you never know.” said Bina. It was tight, but it was a tomb after all, not a place you should wander through. She was the only one who needed night vision, the others needed only a minimal light source. There was a lot of dust and some lichen, but apart from that they didn't even see any spiders.

“Stop!” she and Tung Lashor shouted at the same time, when they reached a large round room with a painting on the floor, it

depicted a warrior in armor with wings growing from his back and a flaming sword in his hand.

“What is going?” Huntara asked, almost bumping into her.

“Such things are usually seen in temples. They're damn suspicious in the tomb.” Bina said, thinking about how to get past them.

“Have you plundered many tombs?” the Wasteland warrior asked in a suspicious voice. She waved her hand and said.

“This is the first one, but I read a lot about it before I came here. If we stood on it, it would probably summon this guy. Looks like an Archon.”

Tung Lashor nodded seriously and said.

“Stained glass golems are the worst. The First Ones loved stained glass.”

Huntara began to look at them as if they were crazy. Well, the galaxy gets a lot crazier.

They crossed the room, walking sideways against the wall. There was a very narrow path specially created for this purpose. The four of them crossed it, she Huntara , Kobold and Tung Lashor , to reduce the likelihood of someone tripping. They walked very carefully so that no one even touched floor. Finally they got to the other side and found themselves in another corridor. This one wasn't long and they found themselves in a large chamber. She was different from the others. It was all covered with the markings of the First Ones, just like the ones Eti saw on her hand. The first thing that caught the eye was a crystal urn standing on a small platform. Above her, of course, was a stained glass window depicting a warrior, just like Adora was turning into...

“Aha! Stained glass golems after all.” she muttered, and the Aspis chief swallowed loudly. “Okay, I have a camera on a telescopic

stick. Let's see what's there.” She said and started to pull out the device. They moved a little closer and then she began to spread her cane. Soon they had to keep it from touching the ground or walls, as this might activate some protection. They managed to move them close enough to get a good look at the urn. It was covered with the same inscriptions in this strange language and a painting depicting a female warrior, probably the previous She-Ra, and another one with a woman in something between a scientist's uniform and priest's robes, and another one, much taller and more dignified, but also a bit unreal. Below was a child, probably a few years old, but wrapped in blankets like a cocoon or something like that. Only there was an inscription in a language she knew, Elvish to be precise .

“Here lies Mara tl'a Teodosis . She was a great heroine who gave her life for each of us, may her sacrifice not be forgotten. May her beloved Light Hope find a path to freedom, and let their child Heart Gift awaken and discover the world beyond Etheria” she read it aloud and asked. “Heart Gift was probably Lady Cala's ancestor who flew to Carurystal, but who the hell was Light Hope?”

Huntara looked at her seriously and said.

“Light Hope was an AI that managed all Etheria, but Heart Gift cannot be an ancestor of someone from another planet, because Mara hid Etheria in Despondos, when she died, no one could leave her.”

Bina shrugged. Women can have many children, with very different partners, and Lady Cala never swore that she was related to Mara, always saying that it was just a guess. Anyway, it didn't matter to her.

“Okay, now we have to think about how to get there and...” she didn't finish because she heard the communicator buzzing, she smiled apologetically at the others and said.

“I just need to talk to my interns.” she said and went to the end of the corridor and answered it there.

“Hi, how are you?” she asked cheerfully, although she was tired.

“Hey Bina. We're flying to Brightmoon right now” she heard Eti's voice, but it was very distorted by interference. “And you know, you can find stray tanks here. They're usually lying around and whoever wants them can take them, and you know, I thought we could get one.

Her first instinct was to protest, but then she realized that since they had the crazy Crushey, the tank wouldn't be any worse, maybe they would just replace the turret on their transporter,

-“Let's think... Will you give com’s to Lilka? “ she asked, knowing that if her students had done something wrong, she would tell without being asked.

“Hey Bina... It's really not our fault.” the red-haired girl confirmed her suspicions. She sighed heavily and just said.

“Explain.”

Lilka took a deep breath and began to explain.

“Mikah was there and we found this Heart Gift, and her mom and mom are dead, and those scars on Miss Daisy's face weren't our fault. Neither do fangs and claws.”

She felt her heart stop and a cold sweat broke out on her back. “It can't be her. Just not her," she thought with horror.

“Lilka, listen to me. Miss Daisy...” she was saying, but the girl interrupted her.

“I can't hear... Alatar says... mountains... Miss Daisy... everything's fine.” and lost the signal. She felt panic rising. *Is that why she was so interested in Eti... Because she reminded her of Catra* she thought. Whatever she was going to find in this tomb, it no longer

mattered at all. She had to save the children, her children. By the gods and devils, she pushed them into the monster's claws. For five years, she and Eti had been hiding from the Lord Admiral. She didn't remeber that there were other monsters in the world. With a nicer voice, using sweeter words, cunning and always polite. Lady Cala must have been involved in all this too. There was no time to think about the fake aristocrat, she had to get out of here quickly and get to Brightmoon, maybe warn the queen, that Catra, or whoever handles security matters in this country. She started running towards the exit and only when she reached almost the other end of the circular room did she realize that she had forgotten about the painting - a trap. She heard a booming "Stand still " and a fiery blade descended on her.

She turned and saw a tall, majestic figure in plate armor. She had wings on her back and a flaming sword in her hand. It emanated a bright light, surprisingly bright and warm. It wasn't blinding at all. He shouted "Stop" and took a powerful swing and slashed Bina , who barely dodged. Behind her, she heard glass breaking.

“Stained Glass Golem.” Tung Lashor groaned despaired, but he struck with his whip. At this time, she attacked the creature with her staff, but all she heard was a loud thud as it hit the armor, and then the creature launched a violent counterattack. Taking advantage of the fact that his back was turned to her, Bina shot him several times, but without much effect. Meanwhile, the Aspis chief and Kablodka were fighting the golem. The fight didn't go well for either of them. Finally, a powerful blow knocked the burgundy-haired woman down.

“Listen, I'm not a servant of evil, and neither are you.”

“You came here to plunder the tomb of Mara, the great heroine. You must die.” He started to make a great swing to kill the traveler, but then she cried out.

“I don't want to rob anything. I came here to give my children peace. Now I have to save them because they are in terrible danger. Look into my heart if you don't believe me.”

The creature looked at the woman for several long moments, its glow becoming more and more intense. She finally said.

“You can leave, but you better hurry.”

And it melted into the floor, becoming a painting again. At this time, there was a sound of breaking glass and the leader of the Aspis called out.

“My name is Tung Lashor, slayer of stained glass golems.”

Meanwhile, she ran to the injured Bina lying on the floor, who whispered.

“Shadow Weaver, I brought Shadow Weaver here.” and she lost consciousness.

The Fall of Kesler – The Homes We Lost

“Hey brother...” Alatar heard the voice of his sister Lasha in his ear, who was sitting on the seat behind him, but thanks to her long dragonkin neck she could look over his shoulder. “You're still playing this sexist speciesist game game about a dwarven miner slaying a dragon to save a princess? She insults your own kind.”

He clenched his jaw in irritation. His sister was a year younger than him, but her favorite pastime was teasing him. He would understand if she was an older brother, but having a younger sister making fun of him and calling him stupid Nerd was unbearable. And not long ago she became a damn defender of the oppressed, especially the Dragonkins. But when uncle Karharot married an elf, she stopped speaking to him along with half of the family.

“It's just a game, a very good game. I don't know why you're looking for additional content there.” he explained, trying not to show irritation. If he had shouted at her, she would have run to her parents and complained... Only her parents weren't here, they were in the capital to stop the ship for them. Their aunt was supposed to send it to them so as not to be thrown together with the rest of the evacuees. Personally, he thought the whole evacuation was bullshit, he watched a lot of videos on the infornet and most of them said that the chances of a real swarm attack were minimal, and their planetary defense was strong enough to repel even a strong invasion, and then there was Atrax with his mighty fleet and immeasurable wealth. They even reportedly hired Lord Admiral Antares and his Fearless Armada. After all, their neighbor won't let the swarm consume their main food source. He had also seen some interesting, if slightly speciesist , videos from a couple of Shirens who claimed that there was no evidence that the swarm had ever attacked any planet unprovoked by the inherent aggression of the unchitinoids . They were a bit strange, but their arguments made sense.

And the worst thing was that he didn't even come back with his school friends, only with his mean sister, because their parents insisted on sending them to a culture camp for Dragonkin. His sister found a few friends there and even a boyfriend, a large, athletic Dragonkin with black scales. Of course, she was so nice that she tried to find him a girlfriend among her stupid friends, and when he wasn't interested in any of them, she happily wanted to set him up with her boyfriend's brother... Too bad. Although, of course, she didn't know the truth.

“You know, this game is also offensive to dwarves. All collectibles are beer or mead, you fight by throwing axes, and you also get lives for collecting coins.” Lasha said, baring her fangs. He scowled at her.

“Dwarves like beer, mead and axes. It's an element of their culture. And it's not just dwarves who like gold.” he explained to his sister as if he were explaining to someone not a year but ten years younger.

“This perpetuates offensive stereotypes about greedy and perpetually drunk dwarves. This is very offensive. And let's not forget about trampling the kobolds. This is a game for speciesists.” his sister giggled.

“You're mean, just leave me alone.” he turned around and crouched down so that his sister couldn't see what he was doing. “Go coo with your fiancé.”

Lasha snorted and left, although he knew he had to be very careful because she was terribly nosy, he had to be on his guard.

For the hundredth time that day he tried to enter the Book of Faces. Of course, he failed. It was irritating at first, they hadn't been able to connect to the internet during their entire stay at camp, so he thought he'd be able to connect while driving to the spaceport, but so far he hadn't achieved anything. He really wanted to talk to his friends. Shiren Kitikie, Kobold Zuruk and Lashunti Grome. They were a close-knit group that played RPGs

and computer games together and created the largest Rainbow Scales fan club on the planet, although he didn't boast about it. Being a fan of a cartoon about princesses transforming into a giant five-headed dragon named Tiamat wasn't something to be proud of. If his sister found out about it, she probably wouldn't let him live. After all she recently talked about a law banning magic and technology than can change someone species, because this is the essence of speciesism, at least for people like her. Not to mention that the rainbow five-headed dragon might offend her personally.

There was, of course, another reason why he was so eager to enter the Book of Faces. Silien. She had only joined their class a year ago, but half the school had a crush on her, or almost all the humanoids…. And he. She was a beautiful elf with silver hair that flowed in the wind, shining like moonlight reflected in raindrops. She was wonderful, phenomenal, like a fey from the first world. She was nice to everyone, even losers like them. Even though she was so beautiful, many people teased her for her unusual origins. His sister made fun of her behind her back, the old Veska of sport pushed her harder than anyone else, but the nastiest were Shiren's Pri triplets. They bullied half the school, and they were the children of the manager of a local supermarket belonging to Aspis and an activist of the Public Health Party, so they were practically unpunishable. A month ago, they surrounded Silien and wanted to smear engine oil on her head, but he was nearby and defended her. He threatened them that he would breathe fire on them, and then they got scared and left them alone. Silien then hugged him and told him that he had acted like a real hero. He had never felt so happy... Of course, then he ended up in the principal's office because the triplets lied that it was he and the elf who attacked them for speciesistic reasons, shouting anti-insectoid slogans. Complete nonsense, because his best friend was Shiren , he even invited him to all holidays, but the director believed the triplets because his wife worked in the Aspis store and he was afraid that she would lose her job. At home, of course, his parents made a fuss about him, because as a Dragonkin he should behave responsibly. By scaring others with

his fiery breath, he harmed the image of the entire species. He ruined the reputation of all the other Dragonkins! At first, they wanted to enroll him in therapy for aggression and antisocial behavior, but his sister came up with this camp so that they could go there together. The camp wasn't that bad, although of course he was terribly bored there. However, before leaving, Silien added him as a friend on Book of Faces and even talked to him, so he decided it was worth it. Of course, he wasn't going to tell the beautiful elf how he felt, and the very thought that Lasha would find out who he fell in love with made his tail stiffen with horror... If his parents found out that he liked Elf girl... He remembered the story of his uncle Karharoth . Of his closest relatives, only Aunt Xinamey and her wife Taler spoke to him, but dad and mom pretended he didn't exist.

His sister was clearly getting bored, so she was about to start teasing him again. He looked out the window and saw that they had stopped in, there were traffic jams. He decided to go out and play since he couldn't talk to his friends. It must have slipped past his private Cerberus. As soon as he stood up, Lasha raised her head and asked, baring her fangs.

“And you, little brother, where are you going?”

He took a deep breath to calm himself down and said

“And I'm going to get some fresh air” he replied, not hiding his irritation.

“Oh, that's good, little brother. Very good. I just hope you play your stupid speciesistjc games.” Lasha said in an innocent voice.

“I will do whatever I like! I'm the older one and I'm supposed to take care of you. That's what my parents said.”

His sister looked at him skeptically.

“If you want, play.” she said with false sweetness. “But if you don't make it in time because you'll play, you'll have to run after the bus... Although it might be good for you.”

He straightened up, angry.

“What are you insinuating!” he growled, and his sister smiled like a snake at a chick.

“You know, I guess that would be the only way to get you to run, which would be good for your fitness. Although if the swarm attacks, it won't be of much use, because the fat guys die first because they stay behind. But you know, then you'll finally become a hero, because when the bugs eat you, they'll get so fed up that they'll fly away, leaving us alone. Hooray.” she giggled.

He looked at Lasha, breathing heavily. He wanted to hit her or yell at her, but he just huffed hard and started to leave.

“I'm sorry, Mati. There will be no Captain Rocket today, maybe I'll play something of ours for you? Maybe Shi and Shu?” Lilka said to her brother while looking through their not very large collection of films. Now it was noon, the time when Mati watched cartoons while dad cooked dinner and mom worked on the farm or vice versa. When her older brother Kay went into the army because the bugs were around the planet, it was up to her to take care of her little brother. She was almost an adult, twelve years old, and could help her parents with almost everything. And now that the school was closed anyway, she had nothing to do. Only there was no television, so she had to come up with some way to take care of him and relieve the burden on her parents. So she found her favorite cartoon, about two friends: Goblin and Shiren, who went back in time to the lost Golarion and experienced strange adventures there. It was a wiser story than Captain Rocket, but Mati really liked Captain Rocket, even though it wasn't for kids his age. She looked at her little brother. He was three years old and his parents adopted him two years ago. She was very happy that she found out that she was going to have a new little brother and she loved taking care of him, although when she had school she couldn't devote much time to him, but now, when there were something like holidays, she could be his beloved sister all the

time.

Mati grimaced when it turned out that it was not his favorite fairy tale, but when Brong the Strong appeared on the screen he started laughing. It was strange, when she was little, she was very afraid of Brong when he roared and threatened Shu that he would make shrimp soup out of her. Then it turned out that he had a good heart and made friends with girls, but she still had nightmares, although she didn't tell her parents about it because they would forbid her from watching her favorite cartoon.

While her little brother was busy watching the series, she went to the kitchen to help her dad. He told her to peel patatos to make colorful fries. My parents didn't make them often because they were fatty and difficult to digest, but they, She, Mati and Kay, loved them. Dad looked very worried, but he tried hard to hide it. She probably guessed what was making him sad.

"Dad, you don't have to worry. Kay and the other soldiers will be fine. They're just stupid bugs." She said to her dad and he hugged her.

"You are wonderful, daughter. Now go help mommy and tell her dinner will be soon. You can't reheat raimbow fries."

She nodded and went outside. She passed the farm buildings and looked around at her family's fields. It would be harvest time soon and there would be a lot of work ahead of them, especially since with everything going on with the Swarm, few farm workers were willing to work. Her parents were very worried about this. They even considered buying agricultural robots, but dad said that in Kesler the robots were very expensive and they would have to take out a loan, and now no one wanted to give it to them. But it wasn't a problem, she would help them, there was nothing to worry about.

She went to the orchard where the pearaples grew and picked one. They were practically ripe. As soon as the harvest begins,

they will make a tart and eat it every day for a month. She ate one more fruit and started looking for her mother. Then she heard a dull bang. She looked at the sky, cloudless and blue. Then she saw lots of flashes on it. They were colorful and bright. Quite nice, but she had the impression that it was something bad...

The birds came. There were thousands of them, whole swarms. She saw every species she knew and plenty she couldn't recognize. There were even Skrats who were now raising chicks, they even took care of one nest with their dad. Now they were all flying west as if something was chasing them.

“Hey, come back for the chicks! During the day I can take care of them, but when it gets dark I have to be at home and now I help my parents take care of my little brother!” she called to the birds, hoping that the pair would hear her. For several minutes she watched the birds fly away, feeling increasingly anxious. Finally they disappeared over the horizon, and then there was silence. Absolute and deafening. Then she felt herself break into a cold sweat of horror.

“It all makes no sense! “ Itel exclaimed and kicked the pine cone angrily. She hated her family, her village and her parents. And the fact that she had six mothers and five fathers and thirteen brothers and sisters meant that she had a lot of people to hate. Only now they closed the school and she had to live in this village all the time. Normally, she only came back here on weekends, and the rest of the week she spent studying at the boarding school, studying with normal kids. Only during holidays and celebrations, or at times like this, did she return home, where, of course, she immediately had to deal with skinning fish, chopping wood, or picking forest fruits, as if they didn't care at all about the education she was getting. She felt like she was in a damn open-air museum. Her family came to the great forests of Kesler to "Recreate the traditional lifestyle of the Wood Elves". Did they want to play full-time reenactors? Okay, but why did they involve their descendants in this, depriving them of a chance for a normal

future? They taught her how to track, fish, repair shoes, everything she needed to survive in the forest. Only normal residents of Kesler could go to the store and buy these things, spending the rest of their time on worthwhile activities. But not they. They couldn't afford anything because, well, they lived in the forest and played self-sufficiency. And she had to be that poor girl from the forest in the whole school, who had to earn extra money after school to buy things that everyone's parents bought for their children. She was worse than the kids from the slums, because they were city kids. Goodfellas.

And she should be happy anyway, because she was allowed to go to the city. All the households contributed to the education of her and her sister of name, i.e. one to whom she was not related by blod, but lived in the same household, to become a doctor and a veterinarian. Even her future was taken away from her. But she had no intention of complying with their plans. She won't become a doctor. She dreamed of a dance school, but she knew that learning was expensive, so she decided to join the army or become a mercenary. These were the only professions performed by "civilized" people in which the skills she had been taught at home would be useful. And the fact that her family were pacifists, although not radical, because they taught her to fight in self-defense, only confirmed her belief that she had made the right choice. But of course that idiot sister of hers spilled the beans... She shouldn't have confided her plans to that treacherous bitch. When she found out about it, she beat the idiot.

The worst thing was that they didn't even punish her, they just looked at her, not even judgmentally, but with sadness, as if they felt sorry for her. So today at noon she went to her blood father Thisolin, her true father. Why couldn't she have a normal family like her friend Viz , the elf, the most handsome in class, whom she had a crush on. He had two fathers, lawyers, a normal family, instead of a damn commune.

She had recently concluded that Thisolin was the only sane person in the entire settlement. And the only one she talked to of her own free will. He wasn't born here, he just arrived twenty

years ago, which explained why he wasn't fooled by the idiotic customs here. He used to be a soldier and was now the village's chief gunsmith. He lived on the outskirts, supposedly because he dealt in hazardous materials, but she suspected it was because he didn't get along with the rest of the settlement. He was a soldier, someone who did useful things. He defended others instead of hiding in the forest like a coward.

His house and workshop were built of real brick and stood near the river, in case a fire broke out... Were they really so stupid as to believe that someone like that would allow a fire to start in his own workshop? She always liked staying in this house, it was a substitute for normal life for her, without being stuck in a wooden hut. However, Thisolin was not inside, so she approached the small dock. She expected to find him grooming the fish, but it turned out he was listening to the radio. Here was the best coverage. When he saw her, he turned off the radio and looked at her with the same concern as the others. She looked down, feeling irrationally guilty. He shouldn't behave like the rest. They stood in silence for a moment, staring at each other, until she asked.

“Are you listening to the news about the war against the Swarm?

“Yes and no.” he said, making her purse her lips in irritation. At school, everyone made fun of elves because they wouldn't give a normal answer even when asked how much is two times two. Seeing her reaction, he explained.

TA Swarm is not an enemy you can wage war against, just like you can't wage war against a locust plague or a zombie invasion. Although a better comparison would be a hurricane or even a supernova explosion. You can try to limit the damage, but there is no adversary, no leader to oppose, with whom to negotiate peace.”

She frowned

“But you never fought the Swarm, in your times we hardly even knew about it.”

Thisolin smiled at her sadly,

“We are not as ignorant as you want us to be, Itel. We are not deaf to the news coming from the great world. We even made some preparations.” he said. She felt anxious. She wanted to ask him what he meant, but then falling stars appeared in the sky. Although not entirely. They were brighter and fell much slower… and much closer.

“Itel, get into the boat and go with the current. I run to inform the others.” said Thisolin . It was the first time she had seen him absolutely terrified.

“But... what's going on.” she asked

“Do what I say!” he shouted at her. For the first time, someone from the settlement raised their voice at her. So she decided to listen to him without arguing. She jumped into the boat moored nearby. Thisolin walked up to her and tossed her two items. One was a heavy revolver and the other was a long knife.

“How you'll have to be strong. You'll have to be brave. You will have to fight with all the strength you have.” and pushed the boat away.

B-nation sighed as she listed all her faults that made her fall so badly that she was assigned to this senseless mission. Her task was to collect as many credits as possible from those who wanted to leave the planet on their own, without counting on rescue from the governments of Kesler or Atrax. The problem was that she didn't own a ship, or even anything that suggested she did. Normally this wouldn't be too much of a problem, she'd just find a few desperate hapless suckers and then leave them for dead. It's sad and mean, but when you're one of the Thousand Daughters, you have to be willing to commit the worst crimes or die, there

were no other options. This time, however, the situation was more complicated because she had to leave the planet on the same ship, otherwise she would be trapped here in the turmoil of war... at best. She had no knowledge of warfare and the mood was optimistic, but she had a bad feeling. But where the fuck could he find a free ship when everyone who could afford it was trying to escape from this planet cursed by devils and demons. However, she had an idea. So she went to a bar run by a former mercenary called Zrikar , a fearsome Vesk, belligerent even for a member of his species.

The interior was crowded and noisy as if nothing had happened. Well, the local customers were mostly veterans of many wars. They were not easy to break or scare. A beautiful topless half-elf woman approached her, apparently her "family's" preferences were well known here, but she paid no attention to it. She was a professional, and unlike most of her sisters, she was able to control her urges… usually…

“Take me to the boss.” she ordered and the girl nodded. For a while, they walked among the noisily partying patrons of the bar. Erotic dancers of various genders and species danced, while Ork metal, Shirean pop and Skittermander rap could be heard in the background . The boss sat in a dusty armchair, and next to him sat two voluptuous and armed Ramiel women, half women, half snakes... They looked like sisters, but she wasn't sure.

“Znikar , we need to talk.” she said, but Vesk interrupted her with a growl.

“NO!” she heard and the lizard showed its fangs in an extremely nasty smile.

“But I need a ship.” she said, silently praying to the mother of rats that no one would hear the desperation in her voice.

“Like everyone else on this planet, but there are no ships anywhere, and even if I had the entire fucking armada of the Aspis consortium, there would be no room for you there. I no

longer do business with the Thousand Daughters, and you are even a pariah among your own people. Jantar has forbidden your sisters and anyone who does not want to make an enemy of him from helping you in any way. Goodbye."

She felt her legs go weak under her. She had known since she was given this mission that she was expected to fail, but she had no idea that things had come this far. She was at the age when the serum slowly wore off. She was also widely respected among the sisters, and apparently her father decided that she should be eliminated as a preventive measure, and this way his hands would be clean, at least in his opinion. But she couldn't let the bugs eat her or Taint kill her. She was about to reach for her gun when she heard a hoarse voice behind her.

"I also need a ship and you will give it to me."

She turned around and saw a fierce-looking Pahtra with black, slightly gray fur, golden eyes, and a screech covered in scars. He had a rifle on his back and a serrated kukri on his belt. Next to him stood a huge orc with a body covered with numerous tattoos. His attire indicated that he belonged to those orcs who wanted to recreate the ancient culture of their species. Significantly, he looked much nicer than his companion. He was armed with a huge two-handed axe. At the sight of them, Znikar jumped to his feet.

"Igzar, you psycho. How did you end up here?" Vesk growled.

"Ship…" Igzar replied, and then there was silence. Their two groups stared at each other for a few moments. It was obvious which side he would choose, but it was not certain whether that side would agree. And then the light went out. She immediately jumped to the side, firing her pistol at the snake woman, and Pachtra shot her companion, and at the same time the orc leapt with his flaming ax and cut Vesk in half. The enemies even managed to shoot. Igzar approached Znikar's corpse and began to search it.

“What is your name?” The orc asked in a friendly voice.

“I'm B-nation number...” she started, but the ax warrior interrupted her.

“Too long, you'll be Bina. Hi Bina, I'm Wagar.” said the Orc, smiling friendly. Meanwhile, Igzar stood up and turned to her.

“Are you going with us.” it sounded like an order that was best not to be disobeyed.

“Aren't you afraid that you will make an enemy of Jantar? – she asked, smiling teasingly, but the pahtra's eyes glowed gold.

“Jantar made a mortal enemy of me by allying with Felix Antares .” there was such terrible hatred in his voice that it would scare even Daemons .

Alatar stepped out of the large bus designed to carry Dragonkins. There was a traffic jam as far as the eye could see, so he assumed he wouldn't get any rest for the next few hours. And that's good, at least he'll be able to play in peace without the nasty wyvern squawking in his ear. He went to the side of the road, ate a bacon bar, bought a lot at the previous store because they were forbidden at the camp, and turned on the game. He was happy when he defeated another dragon in the seventh castle. He deliberately didn't read about her on the infonet to avoid spoilers, so he was sure it was the last level, but of course at the end there was another princess's maid, this time a high elf, who told him that the princess was in the next castle, he almost threw the datapad to the ground, smashing it. He took a deep breath. He wanted to calm down and de-stress after the "Smart" conversation with his sister, but he got even more angry. He looked up at the sky and suddenly saw countless flashes in the sky. They were colorful and chaotic. Only after a few moments of looking at this beautiful sight did he realize what he was looking at. *Space battle, real space battle.* he thought unconsciously. Soon

the flares began to fade and he saw numerous fiery trails of ships entering the atmosphere. *It's an invasion, a real invasion* he thought. The planetary defenses continued to fire and one of the ships was hit and broke into dozens of fragments. He shouted happily, but then he saw a fragment of a destroyed vehicle flying towards them at great speed. For a moment he thought it would hit him, but instead it hit the bus containing his sister and the other Dragonkin from the camp. He stared blankly at the burning wreck for a moment, and then headed towards the city. *What will I tell the family? I was supposed to take care of her* he thought all the way.

Lilka ran in terror, looking for her mother. Something terrible was happening, and only she could do something about it. She heard the animal's mournful cry and ran towards it. She walked through the bushes and saw her mother and Mr. Tut, Shiren, who had been living on their farm for many years and working for her family. Mom had a shotgun in her hands, and Mr. Tut had an electric scythe. In front of them stood an insect resembling a large and monstrous Shiren with huge jaws dripping with green slime. Next she saw two Cowpotamas, they looked half - dissolved. Mr. Tut and Mom also looked burned.

“Tut, take Lilka to the car and drive as far away from here as possible.” her mother ordered him, but Lilka wanted to run to an ax stuck in a nearby stump. But Mr. Tut grabbed her by the waist and started to pull her away.

“MOM” she shouted, but her mother ordered again with a breaking voice

“Just run away!”

This time she didn't resist anymore, she just let Mr. Tut pull her . She immediately heard a gunshot and then a strangled scream. She started crying, but started running with Shiren . After a few unbearably long moments, they reached the family pickup truck

and drove away. She never saw the house, Dad or little Mati again.

A strangers in a friendly land

Chapter Notes

> I changed Rosie nickname to Sparkle Paw because it beter fit her Polish version and is more cute. In future i will coreckt older chapters.

Eti felt better. Despite the grim story with Heart Gift, she felt better. Maybe it was because she was happy to have friends. Itel, Lilka, Alatar and... Sparkle Paw. Even Ireanis and Ilemshaw were fine. She liked Wrongdak too. As for Grimmy, she wasn't sure how she should treat her. She felt a certain fondness for her that was hard to understand for someone who wasn't someone like her. She had the same darkness inside her, which she kept at bay only by force of will. She knew what it was like to draw strength from the fear you induced in others. There, when she moved through the shadows she could see her face and realized that something terrible had been done to that woman too. Maybe not exactly the same as to her, but enough for her to feel some sympathy for her.

She knew that this Grandpa recognized her. Or rather, he saw THAT ONE in her. She shouldn't be surprised, after all, she was known here, though she didn't know why and she wasn't sure she wanted to find out... though she suspected it was inevitable. But what was much weirder was that Grandpa and Grimmy seemed to know each other and the man didn't like her. The latter was quite normal, many people didn't like the Dark Elf, but how could they know each other if this planet had been cut off from the galaxy for thousands of years? But on the other hand, THAT ONE ended up here, so they could get to know each other somehow. Truth be told, she didn't really care. If Grimmy continued to save her and was nice to Sparkle Paw, she didn't care at all. She also hid a dark legacy…

Itel suspected Grandfather of being an Azlantean privateer, which she told them as soon as they were on the Ship. Privately she thought it was nonsense, but Itel was as stubborn as ever. Maybe even a little more. She had a feeling that her friend had been excited ever since she arrived on this planet. She hadn't noticed it before, because her problems obscured her view of what was happening around her, but now, when she felt a little better, she began to notice that the elf exuded determination, as if the future of the galaxy or the entire universe depended on the upcoming events. Maybe that's how it was, after all, it was an extraordinary place and they had a BLONDE and a that Heart here. Itel wanted this Journey, and she agreed because she didn't really care. At least that's what she thought before. Now she wasn't so sure about it, maybe deep inside her torn soul she wanted to meet the OTHER ONE.

Itel was looking here for cure for Captain Blazebringer to help her fight the Swarm. But this poor Heart Gift told about this Heart and then she saw something on the Elf's face that she had never seen before, hope. But this was not a normal hope. There was desperation in it, like the eyes of a predator who had starved for so long that he no longer feared sentient beings and sneaked into herds of cattle or attacked villagers. Eti knew a lot about predators, not only because she was one herself, Jantar gave her a lot of knowledge. Itel was hungry, hungry for victory. All these years she had been feeding on the crumbs of a vague promises of Doctor Leech. Now she smelled a chance for a meal that would finally fill her up. For Itel, the hope of victory was like a drug that made her forget about everything and everyone. It poisoned her thoughts and distorted her conscience. She saw it in her eyes when she pressed Heart Gift to reveal information about this project. If Grimmy hadn't interrupted her, she could have forced the AI to discover the truth about her being alone. She loved Itel, though not in the way the elf girl wanted. That's why it hurt her to see her friend change, but there was nothing she could do. She wasn't good at things like friendship. She didn't know how she could help her, usually the ideas that came to her mind only made the situation worse. She understood that she had to help her

friend somehow, but it wasn't that easy, especially since she had also hurt Itel when she had befriended Sparkle Paw.... No, it wasn't about friendship…

Grandpa decided to stay in the forest, clearly worried, but also clearly furious with Grimmy. So they said goodbye to him and then flew off towards Brightmoon. Bina wanted to talk to them, but they were flying past the mountains, so they lost the signal. Then they will talk when Bina returns to the Valley, or immediately during Victory Day or whatever the name of the holiday was on the occasion of defeating Crooked Face and some wedding... Why was something like a wedding celebrated here...

When they landed and the surprisingly polite landing pad staff took care of their ship. They handed them tourist brochures describing Brightmoon and the surrounding area, encouraging them to participate in the upcoming celebrations, and treats. She wore her usual outfit that covered her face and eyes. She knew that here she could attract the attention of those who knew HER.

Sparkle Paw looked around, beaming with delight. Very literally radiant, because she started to glow.

"It's so beautiful here." she said in sign language and jumped up and did a pirouette. She moved aside. She took off her goggles and looked around. She saw a magnificent palace, or perhaps a castle, made of pale ivory stone that rose above the small town. It looked much neater than Saltmarsh, Clytemnestra or Atrax. It was clean, the houses looked well-kept, everything exuded glamour It was like...

"It's like a fairy tale here." Sparkle Paw exclaimed.

"I don't know what it is, but the glare makes my eyes bleed." she muttered as she left, and the white-haired girl rolled her eyes.

"You are sometimes very grumpy, you know? It's really nice here!" she made a semicircle with her hand. She looked at her sideways. The girl was usually cheerful, but first she was afraid of

what she did in the Wastes, and then she met Heart Gift . Like everyone else, it must have weighed on her that they didn't have the courage to tell her about her fate of hers mothers. Maybe she should do something to make her happy? She liked it here. Probably because it was so fucking lovely here. Sparkle Paw liked things like that because she was sweet and adorable herself... Neither she nor Itel would ever be like that, it was Taken from them by what was done to them. She shouldn't lose it and be like them. Hurt and bitter. She sighed and looked at the tourist brochure.

"Let's see what nice and charming things they have here," She murmured and was about to start looking through the brochure when Alatar suddenly snatched it from his hands and pressed some kind of sweet, probably a toffee into his hand. She growled softly and spoke slowly.

"For the first time in the history of the galaxy, you gave someone treats that you could eat yourself. This could mean one of two things. Either the end of time is approaching and we are all doomed, or you want to distract me from this brochure, in an absolutely dumb way, I dare say, because you should know after all these years that I don't eat sweets, if only because I don't feel the sweet taste. Since even such an absolutely perfect, amazing and unique being as me cannot do anything about the destruction of the universe, it remains to consider the second possibility." she said with irritation as she heard her accent become annoyingly nasal. Ignoring the confused air pad staff, she approached the embarrassed Dragonkin and grabbed the brochure from his hands, and then started looking through it.

She didn't notice anything special at first. A few photos of nice houses and statues, something about local customs and traditions. Some boring maps, no treasures or anything like that. Until she finally saw an announcement about a double wedding. The photo was large, took up the entire page and was colorful. The Double Wedding of Queen Glimmer and Techmaster Bow, as well as the Hero of the Galaxy Adora and Grand Marshal Catra, as it was signed. On the left was a cute girl with pinkish-purple hair and

translucent wings, strangely reminiscent of Captain Moonshadow, and some black guy with a heart on his chest. They both smiled at the person taking the photo. Next was the Blonde, who looked a bit tense, but was also smiling and holding her hand…

THAT ONE! For a moment she felt a cold shudder of fury shake her body, but she controlled it, although it was like swallowing cold fire. It was an instinct, a conditioning instilled in her by Bina's Father, but not only that. Aggression and Anger were part of her personality. However, there was something much more personal going on here. Jealousy… A part of her knew it was irrational, stupid and senseless. But it was always in the back of her mind when she thought about her. But now she was surprised to find that she could control it if she just focused. She took a deep breath and looked at the photo of THE OTHER ONE again. She was muscular and athletic. Her hair was stiffer, like a real Pahtra's. The eyes were different colors, one blue and the other gold. And she had claws on both hands. Now they were out, she herself looked scared. That was probably why the Blondie held her hand so tenderly. In fact, she looked somehow... familiar. She remembered seeing her in her dream, but she couldn't look at it at the time. After a moment, she realized why this face seemed so familiar to her. She saw it every time she looked in the mirror. It wasn't about looks, they were slightly different, but something else. She saw pain and fear in her eyes... or rather, their shadow hidden in the deepest recesses of her soul. She knew him very well. He was also her close friend. But... who did this to her? Who hurt her like that?

"Is everything okay, Eti?" Miss Daisy asked, standing behind her. Now she realized that her friends, as well as the unaware airport staff, were staring at her back, holding their breath. She felt something like shame, so she spoke quickly.

"This queen is quite a pretty chick, totally my type. Do you think that before the wedding they ask if someone don't agrees to the wedding? Because then I would go out in front of the crowd and say that I disagree, and then I would kneel down and propose to her. She would probably be struck by the magnificence of my

personality and leave this guy and marry me. I'm sure Etheria deserves someone as great as me on the throne."

Everyone looked at her. Sparkle Paw and Itel looked at her with resentment, and Miss Daisy looked at her with consternation. It might not have been the wisest thing to say, but she had no other idea to defuse the situation.

They set off into the city. Before they left, Sparkle Paw asked Wrongdak to come with them. The clone was reluctant at first, as if he would rather hide in the ship than visit a place he seemed to know and like, but the former intern talked him into it so nicely that he agreed. She had the feeling that something had happened during that one-day outing with Miss Daisy. He became gloomy and withdrawn. Rosie noticed this too, and tried to comfort the clone and cheer him up, which sometimes worked, but not always. She knew that when someone felt this way, others couldn't help them. It's so easy to break out of this darkness. Maybe she should talk to him, ask about the other one, but she couldn't bring herself to do it. Perhaps sometimes ignorance is bliss. Or maybe rather Truth is a curse. Durnybot knew something too. She saw the scar on his armor and had a feeling from the beginning where it came from, but in this case she didn't want to pursue the topic further. In her mood, she just wanted to go with the flow until she reached the source, the end of this aimless journey.

They reached the outskirts of the city, where platforms stands with food and merchandise, and other attractions related to the Victory Day celebrations were set up between the trees. The town itself, because it couldn't be called a city, looked so friendly that Itel should have had her usual bout of Paranoia. But Elf focused on leafing through the brochure, becoming more and more confused. Finally, she approached a dark-skinned Elf and smiled cheerfully and asked.

- Excuse me, but do you know where the central database, main information center or national library is? I am looking for Information about... The Prehistory of Etheria . – she said without

taking her eyes off the interlocutor. She gues she wanted to look like she was asking an innocent question, but it had the opposite effect. Toshi started flying excitedly around the Elf, trying to bite him. The fox also liked Brightmoon.

“Er, maybe you should check out the library in Mystacor , or the Forest Library of the Techmaster Bow Fathers. We don't have any database, although apparently Princess Entrapta wants to create a planet-wide network using Prime's technology, but in my opinion this is not a very good idea.” answered the passer-by with a slightly nasal accent.

“So you don't have Infonet here?” Alatar asked in a shocked voice. - How you live here without it is the most wonderful achievement of civilization!” he exclaimed with pure nerdy indignation.

“Alatar is right… partly.” Wrongdak suddenly interjected. “I used it on Vesk III and it was very helpful, although some of the information wasn't… what I was looking for. – a blush appeared on the alien's pale face, *From what websites on Vesk III can you get a blush? What can make such Wrondaks blush? So many questions…* she thought, and the clone continued. “If Princess Entrapta wants all of Etheria to be connected by a network, then that's a great idea.”

The elf frowned skeptically at Wrongdak and said a little haughtily.

“Well, you clones probably have had a more... positive experience with the idea of networks or other forms of shared consciousness.”

Alatar looked at the Elf indignantly and was probably about to start arguing about nonsense like a Nerd, so she decided to take over the discussion before it got out of control. She put her arm around the Elf, pulled him towards her and began to explain to him.

“Imagine a place where all possible and impossible opinions boil and mix like in an alchemist's apparatus, so that falsehood, lies

and disinformation can be distilled and can fed t the masses. All possible truths, half-truths, so perfectly mixed together that it is impossible to separate them. Billions of beings with pure hatred for each other, forming factions whose sole purpose of existence is to fight with everyone who disagree with them. The network is not something that connects thinking beings and spreads the truth, but something that allows thinking beings to separate themselves from each other and live in closed information bubbles and have pure hatred for everyone outside of them, and this is only the thinnest layer of the planet, we haven't even gotten to MOORPGs yet. The galaxy still has many wonderful secrets to discover.” she patted the terrified elf on the back.

“My brother-in-law is Queen Glimmer's advisor on the computerization of Brightmoon. I have to warn him.” The elf broke free from her hands and ran towards the castle. Toshi flew after him.

“I've never done so well, I didn't even want to scare him.” she said, looking after the running Elf and summoned the fox with a wave of her hand.

Then she turned away from him and said to the others.

“So what are we supposed to do now? Itel wants to search these databases to find out something about this heart or whatever it was. But then what will we do?” she asked, feeling growing anxiety.

“So what? " Sparkle Paw exclaimed with pure and adorable joy. “We are getting ready for the celebration and we will party with all the inhabitants of Etheria. We will eat delicacies, play games and... dance.” she did a pirouette.” she clapped. “I always wanted to dance all night at a wonderful ball, meet a beautiful prince or princess. And here I can do it.” she laughed soundlessly. Alatar looked absolutely delighted, but she, Lilka and Itel looked at the white-haired girl in horror.

“But how...” she asked in disbelief. “We don't know how to organize balls and parties. We can't just go to the party.”

“Of course you can. It says here that everyone is invited. So so do we. And Miss Daisy will prepare us for the prom! She raised Lady Cala to be a wonderful lady, and she will prepare us for the ball.” she pointed to Ponurka , whose face showed horror. She felt sorry for the dark elf.

She saw the city of Brightmoon for the first time, which was quite funny considering she had been the leader of the Horde for almost a quarter of a century and had previously served on the council of Mystacor for many years. She knew Lynortis, the capital of Carurystal, better than the seat of the queens of Etheria. Now that actually worked to her advantage. There were only a handful of people in the entire city who could recognize her, and only Catra, Adora, and Glimmer could do it from a distance while she was wearing a mask. Of course, it was still risky, but with some precautions, she should be able to avoid recognition. So she pulled her hood over her head and spoke in a low voice, hoping to get lost in the crowd of Brightmoon visitors for the holiday. In fact, no one paid any attention to her, her wards attracted her much more, although in Etheria, marked by a long war and with so diverse population, they did not stand out as much as they could, for example, on Carurystal. She even had the impression that Etheria was more alien to them than they were to Etheria . They unconsciously huddled together and looked around as if they were making their way through cursed ruins located in an unexplored jungle. This sight would probably be funny if it weren't so sad. Anyone who knew the origins of this unusual group could feel nothing but helpless sympathy when they saw the distrust with which they looked into the friendly faces of the inhabitants of Brightmoon. *Did she look at everyone this way during your first days? How did she feel seeing this beauty and splendor? I would like to see it, but it is a foolish desire. Selfish and cruel in its own way. My mere presence, the mere fact that I am alive, would not allow her to enjoy such hard-won happiness? Wouldn't it be better*

for me to stay dead for her and Adora! she thought, clutching the brochure. She only glanced at it because she didn't want to arouse suspicion, then she would look at the photo and see how the women who could have been her daughters had changed, if only she had let them, if she had been a better person.

Rosie brought her out of her thoughts. When the girl called out that Miss Daisy would definitely help her get ready for the ball, she was at first going to say that she didn't have time, but then realized with horror that she had more than enough time. Until meeting her uncertain allies on Victory Day, she had absolutely nothing to do. Even Lady Cala left her alone to complete her part of the mission. She could have refined her plan a bit more, but it didn't change the fact that there was no rational excuse to refuse them. She wasn't sure if she wanted that anyway. She liked these kids and knew they deserved this little bit of joy in their difficult and sad lives. She sighed and said slowly, barely keeping herself from rubbing her temples.

"I can do it...." she looked at Alatar, tattooed and scowling at everyone, with many implants in her body, Lilka holding a blade on her shoulders that could cut someone in half, and at Eti, armed with a sniper rifle, waving her tail uncertainly, although in her case All she had to do was reveal her face to cause a stir. "But it will take a lot of work and a little help on your part." she added and felt Ireanis pat her on the back.

"I'll help too. Parties and partying are my specialty!" exclaimed the silver-haired sorceress. She wanted to say, "I'm not surprised at all," but she bit her tongue just in time. There was no point in making an enemy of a sorceress out of stupid malice. Especially since she was so much more talented than anyone could have guessed. What secret could she be hiding? This is another mystery she had to solve, but this matter is in the future.

"First we need to go to the tailor to make you some clothes. Unless you already have some." she asked, looking at the kids. Itel blushed, Rosie looked embarrassed, Eti looked ostentatiously at her coat, although judging by the nervous movements of her

tail she was as confused as the white-haired girl, Lilka crossed her arms on her chest and only Alatar raised his hand.

“I have formar outfit, a suit.” Alatar said in a timid voice.

Everyone looked at him in pure disbelief, even her.

“When did you buy your suit, drakey?” Eti asked.

“Well, on Akiton , you can also buy formal clothes there, even for Dragonkins.” explained the technomancer

“In a minute. You bought clothes for the prom, even though we all thought we were going to a land haunted by every possible species of devil.” Eti asked in disbelief, and Dragonkin lowered his head and said quietly.

“You know, I preferred to be prepared.”

“I'd rather not ask what else you were prepared for.” the cat girl muttered. “But I like my outfit there. It is comfortable, dangerous and very discreet.” she connected the cloaking field and did a backflip. She was still noticeable, although the cloaking field made her blend in perfectly with her surroundings

“I always wear a traditional orc warrior outfit, which fits perfectly everywhere, and I have a special compartment for my sweets.: said Lilka and took out a large handful of toffee.

Only Itel and Rosie remained. Both girls looked embarrassed. Rosie was the first to speak.

“I've never been to a ball, but I'm almost sure I can dance, it's practically the same as dancing, only without broken bones and broken teeth. Only I don't have money for a dress. Dr. Quinn paid me with credits, or rather the government pays me, and here they are worth little.” the white-haired girl lowered her head sadly. She sighed and smiled slightly at her.

“I'm sure Bina wouldn't deny you money for a dress and all the necessary things, and if you don't want her to pay, then on Lady Cali's behalf I have some funds at my disposal that are more than enough.” then she looked at Itel. “And you, my dear? What you need?”

The Elf smiled sadly.

“When I went to school in Kesler, i was getting ready for the big Annual Ball. I worked after classes all month to buy my dream dress, and I even bought it, but...” The Solarian wiped her eye and sniffed. Then Rosie hugged the elf with all her might. From the corner of her eye, she saw that Wrongdak also wiped the tears from his eyes and walked over to Itel.

“I don't know much about Etheria's customs, I haven't lived here very long, but as best as we can, Emily and I will help you prepare for Victory Day.”

For a moment, there was a moment of friendly, melancholy warmth that she had never experienced in her long, wicked life. Eti interrupted her and asked one very important question.

“Bina wanted to sell Ashrak here straight from Atrax. I think we need to get a permit for her. According to the brochure, this type of thing is handled by Swiftwind”

Meanwhile, another ship had now entered Etheri's orbit, it was much smaller than Bina's. Typically, such ships were used by the Hell Knights to pursue scums and criminals, although the Order of the Eclipse rarely used them for this purpose. His only passenger did not introduce herself to Susan by her name given on the distant Minitar, apart from her title, after all, she had not come here to represent the Order of the Eclipse. This was her private mission. She did not wear armor or even a representative uniform, only a simple cloak in the colors of the Order. She took the sword though, this planet might be the friendliest place in the galaxy, but

she would never allow herself to be left unarmed, and besides, something told her it was best not to leave that sword unattended. Then she left the ship, her golden hair illuminated by the bright light of the moons.

Betrayals and disappointments

Dilayla felt disgusted with herself. She was a traitor, and of the worst possible kind. Most betray for some benefit. Money, position or something similar. Others were motivated by envy or old grudges. There were even those who took excuse in the Ephemeral Greater Good, whatever it might be. However, she betrayed out of cowardice. And not because someone was threatening her loved ones or even herself. She was scared to make a decision. Take the risks, knowing that whatever choice you make will have consequences. She was a mercenary who fearlessly threw herself into battle, but she was afraid to take responsibility for what might happen. This could have had a relationship, after all, throughout her life someone else had been telling her what to do. First her parents, then the Order, and finally those who paid her to risk their lives and... take them from others. She realized it was an easy life, in a way she never had to truly grow up. All she had to do was listen to orders and go with the flow, and she would have peace of mind. Even Bina's children , with all their unruliness and chaotic nature, were more adults than she was.

She was a traitor three times over. She betrayed herself. She served Iomadae, the heiress. Her goddess demanded of her followers to be brave, truthful and above all, to stand up for the weak and oppressed. And she simply broke all these rules by remaining silent. She was not worthy of serving the Goddess. Iomadae was gracious, but even she could not tolerate such a betrayal of her orders.

But she also betrayed her friends. These poor kids were at the mercy of such a twisted, vile creature. Okay, these weren't just defenseless kids, in fact they were dangerous and a little scary. They looked more like a squad of mercenaries than a best friends squad. But they couldn't do much against the dark sorceress. He probably stays close to them because he wants to use them as

hostages or as a human shield, although in this case she may make a mistake, they will not be willing to allow themselves to be subdued, anyone who tries this will regret it bitterly. But evil Hag can manipulate them to suit its purposes. Bina's wards were hotheaded, and Rosie, naive and good-natured, it was easy to use lies and deceit to exploit them into doing what she didn't have the strength or courage to do, as corrupt leaders often did. Others have always been just tools to them, extensions of themselves at best, damned shadows that exist only to do their will. Over the course of almost a quarter of a century, she's encountered many similar bastards who treat others like things. She even got rid of a few herself.

She also betrayed the inhabitants of this planet. She didn't owe them anything, after all, they weren't her compatriots or someone she had promised to protect. However, the inhabitants of this planet were nice, as she could see during their expedition.

The five of them set off immediately after landing. They took one of the anti-gravity vehicles of the local faction of the Horde, which seems completely unlike Prime's technology, which they could see, for example, in that monastery. The driver was a short hedgehog or echidna person who radiated a laid-back attitude. The vehicle was agile and surprisingly fast, making Lady Cala's hair flow in the wind like bright yellow ribbons. If it were anyone else, she would probably be charmed by the sight, but not in the case of this bitch. She didn't like her from the very beginning, long before hook discovered who her mentor was. She was too perfect, inhumanly perfect, though not invincible, as Rosie had proven, but the white-haired girl was an enigma in her own right. There was evil hidden in her. Not Darkness, darkness sometimes hid in the souls of quite decent people. Some people just managed to fight it within themselves. As the followers of Serenae said, true goodness lay in the hearts of those who were able to break free from the shackles of vice, not those weak, arrogant Puritanicals who in their pride claimed that sin had no access to them. Lady Cala was pure evil. Cheerful, simple and easygoing, hidden behind a veil of benevolent nobility. Now that she knew that Miss Daisy was a Shadow Weaver. This tried to look at things from a different

angle, but many things did not fit what one would expect from someone like the person in Wrongdak's story. Lady Cala did not at all look like a girl intimidated by an evil sorcerer. Their relationship was... more equal. Under the guise of pretending to be a well-born maiden and her noble and wise mentor, there was something completely different. There was mutual dislike between them, contempt bordering on hatred, as if they were rivals forced to cooperate by a greater, much more significant power. But who or what was she? Could it be Lord Admiral Antares, another monster they brought to this beautiful place. Although she had to admit that it all didn't come together very well. The Lord Admiral and Lady Cala had a distant respect for each other, but an air of superiority that was unlikely in a master and a servant. They could have pretended, but according to her experience, such prideful and arrogant people could never agree to be subordinated to someone who had no direct control over them.

And there was something else. After learning who Antares was, Miss Daisy fell into depression for several days, accompanied by drinking spree. It had made sense to her at the time, but now she saw it from a completely different perspective. Perhaps it wasn't out of guilt for collaborating with a war criminal, but if she was associated with the Horde and that Horde Prime... Or rather Wronghordak's brother… She wasn't sure what the relationship between the clones actually was. Maybe she was just jealous that that bastard Antares would take away her planet, which she intended to conquer only for herself. But her words, her assurances that there's a much bigger game at play here... Fuck! She was just a regular mercenary, not a damn hero. She decided to believe the one thing Shadow Weaver said. “And what she wants most is to bathe in blood.” Every time she looked at that beautiful, gentle face, blue eyes and gracious smile, she knew it had to be true.

They saw a town, small by galaxy standards, their driver said.

“I'll take you there, you still have to find another means of transport. I don't feel like driving you all over Etheri because I don't want to camp under the moons, especially since now it's

said that strange beings wander the lonely places after dark. Shadows and ghosts. I tell you, shadows and ghosts.” he shouted overly dramatically. Arkan-tar nodded in understanding.

“The undead plague old ruins like rats plague landfills. In my profession, you have to be able to deal with these kinds of problems.” he smiled at the hedgehog , who scratched his cheek in surprise.

“Usually everyone tells me that I've heard too many scary campfire stories, but here you go, foreigners believe me.”

“These foreigners may even give you good advice.” Rechiza said in a serious voice. “Don't approach the shadows without a flaming weapon, and if you encounter a ghoul, a humanoid monster with long claws and fangs that reeks of rotten flesh, run away, because if it hurts you, you may contract a disease that will make you one of them. So if a ghoul scratches you and there's no healer blessed by the righteous gods, you'd better take your own life.”

Their driver stared at Lashnti with his mouth open, probably hoping she was joking, but the Warper was, as always, completely serious.

“Back to more... pleasant matters, would you mind selling this vehicle to us?” Lady Cala asked, smiling gently.

“For how much?” driver asked in a skeptical voice

“Three thousand swords.” Lady Cala said. The hedgehog whistled in surprise. It must have been a considerable sum of money, since they paid twenty swords to rent a vehicle for the day. Although their currency was not easily converted into the local one, and their equipment could be sold here with multiple currency exchange rates, it was still an absurd extravagance. Previously, she would have simply suspected that the aristocrat ostentatiously did not care about money, but now she knew that there were dark intentions behind her decisions. The hedgehog thought for a moment and then shook his head as he answered.

“Uh, no. It's a lot, but I would quickly spend that kind of money on stupid things, and then I'll be poor. I'd rather save up for a house slowly, or I'll buy another one and employ my brother.” he said, ending the conversation, but Ldy Cala did not want to let go.

“You might be interested in the amount of four thousand swords.”

This time their driver turned towards them and started twitching his black nose, clearly curious. However, she sensed that the other participants of their expedition did not like the aristocrat's extravagance, so she decided to take advantage of the opportunity and interfere.

“I know that the noble lady is used to being driven everywhere, but unfortunately during such a trip you have to give up comfort. I can walk everywhere there on my own. I suspect the rest of my companions don't mind either.”

Arkan-tar nodded, smiling sadly.

“We all get used to comfort very easily, but with such limited resources, we will probably have to give them up.”

“When we agreed to this undertaking, we accepted that we would have to face much greater adversities.” said Rechiza. The Warper had been strangely somber since meeting Adora.

Lady Cala looked at the mercenary as if she had only just realized that the other woman could talk. She smiled at her sadly and somewhat indulgently, as if she were a child who didn't understand anything.

“I'm not the pampered aristocrat you want me to be. I can, if necessary, endure hardships that people like you cannot even imagine. However, I believe that the mobility provided by such a vehicle is crucial to achieving the goal of our mission. Besides, Dr. Quin needs this vehicle to transport his things. “ she pointed to several boxes with strange devices that were supposedly necessary for the scientist. Ysoka nodded at the aristocrat and said.

“That's true. If Rosie hadn't turned out to be such a stinking lazy, or if you had let me keep Palidus Valgus as a volunteer intern wouldn't be a problem, but I would have to abandon extremely expensive equipment, paid for by the government, to the savages living on this backward planet.”

The hedgehog person gave Dr. Quinn a very offended look and Dilayla rolled her eyes.

“This “Palidus Valgus' name is Wrongdak, you should have learned that by now, and if you're worried about your gadgets, I can carry them. I finally have power armor, all you have to do is pack them nicely and I can carry them to the other end of this continent.” she said in a tired voice. The scientist considered her words for a moment, then nodded.

“Sure, at least you won't be as lazy as that deaf girl.”

Rechiza felt disappointed... even though she should have felt happy. Just like that, any fears about what Etheria might be disappeared like mist in the wind, revealing a beautiful summer morning. Now she could explore Etheria's secrets as she pleased, or not, nothing forced her to do anything. There were Lictor's orders , but they could wait. She found no convincing evidence that Miss Daisy or Lady Cala posed a threat to their expedition, although she had to admit that she hadn't been keeping a close eye on their activities lately. Other things were on her mind.

She met one of the First Ones... For her, it was something much more important than meeting one of the gods, although for such Anacites she was probably a god. Throughout her life, she researched the secrets of this extinct race. Or rather, a race that everyone thought was extinct. She never thought it was possible to meet a representative of an ancient civilization just like that at a marketplace... Even though these kids were the first who met her... Just wandering around the wilderness of Icarus. Perhaps she should be jealous, if it weren't for the fact that this Adora turned

out to be such a... Disappointment. One would expect the last representative of one of an extinct, eldritch civilization to exude wisdom accumulated over millennia of enlightenment and knowledge beyond mortal understanding. That her body and mind would be the epitome of perfection. And she was such an ordinary young woman. Yes, athletic, as far as she could tell, quite attractive, but otherwise more than ordinary. Lady Cala is a more wonderful creature in every way, if she claimed that she was a full-blooded representative of this wonderful and terrible species, she would believe her without hesitation. But that woman was so full of doubts, so unsure of herself, lacking faith in her own power. And she undoubtedly had this power. She saw it when she transformed into this She- Ra person . This being... was a fragment of divinity, the seed of a god that was yet to sprout and reach its full glory. Only the gods were not supposed to be so human, so mundane. It was not the kindness and love of ordinary beings but the unshakable, unwavering power that evil feared the most. And yet everyone claimed that she was the one who defeated Horde Prime. It questioned everything she had been taught and what any reasonable being believed.

The city had at most a few thousand inhabitants. It was built on the trunks and branches of several gigantic Baobabs or similar trees, but several newer and more modern buildings were built on the ground. It looked like something straight out of a children's fairy tale. It was called Treehouse, what great creativity in choosing the name, and it was located on the border between the wastelands and the Singing Jungle. The surrounding areas were a forest steppe, a bit friendlier and more densely populated than Wastes. The city looked friendly, which shouldn't surprise her, so it was a perfect base. Here they also made their first, although absolutely unexpected, discovery.

They stopped at what looked like a parking lot for similar vehicles to the one they had rented. There was a notice board nearby. The first one to notice it, of course, was looking at the large poster and adjusted his glasses a few times, and then said, smiling with the corner of his mouth.

“That's interesting... Look. – he called to them. As they approached, she saw the announcement of the wedding that the AI had mentioned. There was a winged girl with purple and pink hair who had something familiar about her, a tall and handsome dark-skinned man, Adora, whom they already knew and…

“It's impossible...” she said quietly in disbelief. At first glance, she took her for that cat-like girl from Bina crew... She thought her name was Eti. She didn't look closely at the girl, she was too unstable to associate with, but the person on the poster looked remarkably similar. Not identical, but very similar. Like siblings or cousins at best.

“I think someone was hiding something from us.” Arkan-tar said with a dark note in his voice, but Dilayla let out a broken laugh and said with undisguised contempt in her voice.

“If you took the trouble to make friends with our captain and her wards you would know who she is.”

“Well, I noticed that you have developed a very close relationship with this Bina. Would you kindly enlighten us? – said Arkan-ta with his inseparable smile. The mercenary ignored his insult and began to explain.

“Her name is Catra, it even says it here.” Dilayla pointed to the inscription on the poster. “As far as I know, she's sort of Eti's sister. Both were created by Bina’s Father. Catra was born as a baby twenty-something years ago, but Eti was born as a teenager. For some reason, Jantar did not like Catra, andsold her to Doctor Sidonius, who used her in an experiment that brought her to Etheria. I know the rest from the stories of Wrongdak, who doesn't know everything. She was found by the Horde from Etheri and placed under the "care" of Shadow Weaver, a dark sorceress who was the right hand of the local Horde leader and the brother of our dear Wrongdak. This dark bitch was extremely cruel and mean to Catra. She was also close to Adora and probably not in a sisterly way since they want to get married after all Catra overthrew that dark bitch and practically led the Horde herself

until Hord Prime came along. I'm not entirely sure what happened next, but I guess she got lucky because, hey, she's a grand marshal and she's getting married, so she obviously made better life choices than I did.” the mercenary rubbed her chin in somewhat theatrical thought. She and Arkan-tar stared at Dilayla in disbelief, so she added. “Do you see how much you can achieve when you are just nice and talk to your fellow passengers?”

Dr. Quin was paying no attention to their conversation, and Lady Cala… She had the kind smile on her face, as usual, but out of the corner of her eye, he saw that she was clenching her fist so tightly that her knuckles were turning white.

“This is disturbing information, although I'm not yet sure what it might mean.” said the Aristocrat thoughtfully. Well, she wouldn't care about the fate of both cat girls if it weren't for their connections with Dr. Sidonius, who created her cybernetic eyes. She didn't trust the ancient vampire, if only because he was an ancient vampire, but now it turned out that he knew about this planet and was trying to find a way to get there. She shouldn't have felt surprised, because after all, he wasn't her friend, or even her ally, just someone who gave her cybernetic eyes, probably as part of some experiment, but she still felt disappointed, although probably due to her own ignorance. So far, she has been accustomed to being the best-informed person, someone to whom others turn with questions, but recently she has come to the conclusion that her ideas about the world around her have little in common with the reality surrounding her. A damned uneducated mercenary whose worth was measured by how many people she could kill or maim in an hour knew more than she, who had devoted her life to discovering ancient and dark secrets. Something like that took away my confidence in my own competences.

“Well, Miss Dilayla gave us an enlightening lesson on friendship, cooperation, and openness, and we were able to gain information that we otherwise would not have been able to obtain. Congratulations. Now maybe we will look for an inn or hotel to

rest and prepare for the purpose of our trip." said Arkan-tar with a smile. She sighed and nodded.

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The inn was large and a bit empty, but it was surprisingly pleasant. She felt the aroma of apple pie wafting around her, making her mouth water. If someone had told her a few weeks ago that she would drool on Etheri smelling the apple pie, she would have thought him crazy. The sanctuary was run by a pair of Strix, winged, lightly feathered people with bird legs. These two had feathers like colorful tropical birds. They were happy to see them. They learned that many guests had gone to Brightmoon for the wedding and Victory Day. To her surprise, the owners looked at her with sadness and compassion.

"Oh, you're Vespa, but I guess you're not from here because of those metal eyes... We didn't know that representatives of your people live in the empire. Horde Prime did not like your race. Here you managed to hide in the depths of the Singing Jungle thanks to the power of Princess Sweet Bee, she is also one of you. But you didn't have princesses... It must have been hard for you... Giving you a free apple pie..." she smiled friendly, and she smiled back at her with as nice a smile as she could muster, but the effect was moderate, and she said.

"We are not from the empire, but from the Pact Worlds. Only recently did we learn about its existence."

The owner of the Inn's eyes widened.

"We had a few non-Etheri people here, but no one from outside the Empire. We didn't even know anything existed outside the empire. Horde Prime claimed to be the ruler of the known universe.

Then Arkan-tar sat down next to him, bowed courtly and said.

"Megalomaniacs like Horde Prime often claim that they have divine attributes. This is the defining characteristic of

megalomaniacs, and I am Arkan-tar, a scholar from Kemanis University.” Verthani smiled, in his opinion, disarmingly, but the woman obviously liked it, because she blushed and asked.

“Oh, university! This must be a great place.” she said with delight. She wanted to roll her eyes, but even her natural eyes couldn't do that because they were faceted .

“This is one of the greatest universities in the galaxy. It is located on Absalom Station, the largest space station in the Galaxy. It is the center of the galaxy and over two million creatures live there permanently, but if we include guests from all over the galaxy , there will be at least twice as many.”

You used the word galaxy three times too many in one sentence, she thought sarcastically.

Soon, the owners husband joined the conversation with Verthani, who started telling stories to both of them. She snorted contemptuously. Such an intelligent man should focus and not allow himself to be distracted by such mundane matters. Soon they rented five rooms and had basically nothing to do until the morning.

Two hours later she sat at the table feeling broken. She ordered an apple pie and devour it all herself. Now she was looking gloomily at Arkan-tar, who was telling his owners about one of his numerous and probably imaginary adventures, and she was eating date bread with honey and drinking hibiscus tea. It was already dark outside, and Lady Cala went out to look around or do something similar, in her current mood she didn't really care. Fifteen minutes after the aristocrat left, Dilayla approached her with two mugs of cider.

“I'm not interested in women.” she said harshly and the mercenary she glanced first at Arkan-tar, then at her, and raised an eyebrow.

“I just noticed who you're interested in. And I really don't want to fuck every woman I approach. Even in Bina's case, I had to drink half a bottle of elven wine first, really good...”

“What do you want from me?” she interrupted the half-elf, a bit concerned about her talkativeness.

“Well, now when Lady Cala's left us... I have to tell you what else I found out.” the half-elf took a large sip of cider, as if she needed to give herself courage. “Miss Daisy is Shadow Weaver.”

She felt as if she had hit the ground after falling from a very high height. Previously she felt that she knew too little, now she realized that she knew absolutely nothing.

“How did you come to such a ridiculous conclusion?” she said slowly, trying to sound more confident than she felt. The mercenary smiled not very cheerfully and said.

“Shadow Weaver was a dark sorceress and, surprisingly, the ruler of shadows. Her face was scarred and she had fangs and claws. And I saw Miss Daisy's real face. Moreover, this woman knows things that the tutor of such an aristocrat should not know. And her suspicious interest in Eti, as if she recognized her as her pupil, or rather someone very similar to her.”

She listened to the half-elf's argument in silence, thought for a moment and spoke.

“It's only circumstantial evidence. Strong circumstantial evidence, I must admit, but still circumstantial evidence on the basis of which we should not draw such far-reaching conclusions...”

“She confess it when I asked her about it.” Dilayla interrupted her.

Now she just stared at the mercenary until she simply asked her.

“How did she confess?”

The half-elf shrugged.

“I went to see her right after we landed here. I admit that at first I wanted to kill her, but she managed to talk me out of it. She simply said it would be pointless and might even make things worse.”

Rechiza laughed briefly. She turned out to be an idiot. She assumed that Mr. Daisy was either an Old One cultist or a member of the Dominion in Black. But something so mundane and yet extraordinary was beyond her comprehension.

“And what now? Next you're going to tell me that this woman intimidated Lady Cala and now we have to save the beautiful woman.” She asked But Dilayla shook her head.

“No... It's Lady Cala that we should all be afraid of. “ the fear in the mercenary's voice made her shiver.

Calamity knew this planet to be a great disappointment. Yes, it was quite nice here, but there was nothing to fight over so hard She guessed it had to do with her inability to use Magic. Nyarlathotep, in their infinite wisdom, decided that she should not have access to this power, leaving her with only limited psionic abilities . She couldn't understand it, but even she was just a weak pawn in the game of great powers and had to come to terms with their will.

She was glad that the younger monster had gone his way, although she didn't like that Shadow Weaver was left with that scabrous bunch, but that was the will of the Creeping Chaos, they wanted the dark Sorceress to try to carry out her plan . She had no intention of standing against her.

And today she finally saw this creature. She had a rightful contempt for Adora and was disgusted by the little monster, but when she saw Catra she wanted to put out her claws and tear that face apart, even though it was only a poster. This being had stolen her destiny and condemned her to this meaningless

existence. She swore to herself that she would not leave this planet until she turned that creature's life into a nightmare...

But now she had to fulfill the will of the Creeping Chaos. She sensed where she needed to go. She could feel places, where rituals were performed in the glory of blasphemous entities. At first she considered letting her hosts wait and hanging the driver by his own intestines, but she decided that would be terribly petty. In the future, she will make a rug from the skin of his entire family.

The meeting was to take place in the primary school building, which must be admittedly a surprising but ingenious choice. She entered the classroom and was dismayed to notice that there were children's drawings hanging on the walls depicting an idiot, a monstrosity, or a glitter queen. Eight cultists were waiting for her here, under normal circumstances it would have been pitifully few, but on this planet cut off from the rest of the galaxy, it was all she could count on.

“Welcome and rejoice, for you stand before the face of Calamity, Perfection Incarnate.”

Few happy moments

Alatar actually liked this place. It was colorful, cheerful and a bit rustic, but actually really nice. A bit like in the RPG sessions he played in... in his old life... Here it was like in one big LARP ... There wasn't even a network, although in LARP it was usually not there to stick to reality, and not because after It just wasn't there... He hoped, however, that it would be created soon, maybe they would even need a network specialist. Maybe he could get a job here...

Itel looked beautiful when she smiled. I wonder if she knew about it? Probably not. Itel smiled slightly more often than Eti, and sometimes he had the impression that she smiled less often, because in the cat-like girl's eyes he often saw sparks of joy, a bit similar to the one he often saw in his sister... Now Itel was looking around with a joyful curiosity not much less than Rosie's... He liked the deaf girl, and not just because Eti was attracted to her, which made his chances with Itel... a little better. She was simply joyfull and nice to everyone... Moreover, she had amazing skills, like a hero from a story, although that was not the only thing. Sometimes he felt like the magic around her was working strangely. He noticed it in the monastery, it seemed as if it was slightly disturbing their aura, as if it was sucking out the threads of power. Then he quietly cast a few spells on her, but he didn't discover anything new. However, he didn't tell anyone about it, if only because he was cast spells on the girl without her consent. Rosie might get offended, or Eti might do something very Eti-like, like throw a grenade into his cabin. And it didn't matter that he had no malicious intentions, he was just curious what the deal with the deaf girl was.

They found a tent where Swiftwind , the main coordinator for the Victory Day celebrations, was supposed to be staying. Or something like that. Eti started sniffing, and he also felt a strange smell that he couldn't recognize, even though he wasn't an

authority. They waited for a moment, wondering what to do, but as there were no sounds coming from inside, apart from a quiet humming, Lilka shouted.

“Swjftwind!”

Almost immediately, a horse with rainbow feathered wings and a horn on its forehead jumped out. They were white colored and had a rainbow mane. I think these creatures were called Airicorns or something like that.

“Did someone called SWIFTWIND!” the horse shouted.

“Yes, Lilka. “said Eti, pointing to Lilka, whose eyes sparkled with hearts.

“Horsee!” the red-haired girl said with delight.

“I prefer to be called Swiftwind “ said the horse, a bit confused.

“Listen, Hoofy. We came here for two very important matters for the future of the universe. Firstly and most importantly, we want to obtain permission to sell Ashrak , it is a completely harmless drink that you can drink without fear of your health and without the risk of addiction.”

“And I have a question. Have you heard anything about the artifacts here? Where can you read about it? In some royal library or museum.” itel asked .

“ And let me ask you a question, where is the best one tailor here... Or at least the good one, because we are probably not as rich as the princesses and we cannot wear such wonderful costumes.” Rosie asked.

“And as for my second question about a mystery that touches on an issue that worries all scientists in the Galaxy...” Eti began, but he interrupted her.

“Don't start, Eti. We all know what you want to ask.”

The feline friend turned to him and spoke in that strange nasal accent she got when she started talking nonsense.

“How are you supposed to know that? You have developed the ability to read minds, or perhaps you have mastered the secret art of predicting the future. Tell us, Drakey, everyone is listening.” she started wagging her tail violently.”

“Maybe we should let the girl ask a question. It's interesting what the galaxy says about Swiftwind” Airicorn asked .

“Okay Eti, ask what you want...” he said with resignation and then Eti asked.

“If I prepared you for dinner, would you count it as white or red meat?”

Swiftftwind then opened its mouth and stared at them with its mouth open.

“You just met Eti and her wonderful sense of humor.” he explained to the winged horse in an apologetic voice.

“I have no sense of humor!” Eti muttered in an offended tone.

Swiftwind sat down, head down , and said in a saddened voice.

“I'm not that amazing anymore. People used to be in disbelief that they saw a horse talking, but now no one pays attention to it. Do you think I've Boring?”

Rosie walked up to him and hugged him comfortingly and said

“You know, Mr. Swiftwind. We have a telepathically talking three-eyed fish with tentacles on board. This is a high bar. For us, a talking horse does not make an impression.” she patted him friendly on the head, and Swiftwind smiled , which actually looked quite nice, but then he looked at Alatar, opened his eyes wide, jumped up to him so that they were almost neck and neck and shouted

“Wait, you're a Dragon! Quite small but still a dragon!”

Alatar sighed heavily and said.

“I am not a dragon, but a Dragonkin. This is completely different, please don't confuse us.:

“This Dragon is talking!” exclaimed the aricorn as if he hadn't heard what the technomancer was speaking to him.

“That's what I'm saying... we've been talking from some time. And most of both dragonkins and dragons can speak and yes it's not true at all that there are dragonkin riders.” he blurted out before he could bite his tongue. He was glad that Lilka was in a horse trance, because she would probably tell him that he had just lied.

“It's kind of good because sometimes I feel like Adora would prefer me to be a dragon.” Swiftwind said with sadness in his voice.

“Well, could you please answer our questions?” said the technomancer, mentally promising himself that in the future he would leave him to be eaten by Eti.

“Oh, I'll show you around” exclaimed Aricorn .

Wonderful... Dragonkin thought.

She watched her temporary wards interact with Adora's mount with some amusement. Of course, she did it from a safe distance. They spent so much time together during the occupation that he would probably be able to recognize her voice. That's why she preferred not to risk it.

“Who do you think built this castle? It's damn big, even in Lastwall they didn't have such big ones... Although they defended themselves against Orcs there, but real, wild ones, not like the

modern ones.” said Ireanis, looking at Brightmoon Castle . She also looked that way and thought about it

“Honestly, I never thought about it. Brightmoon has always been something that just is. I used to think that Angela's ancestors built them, but now I would put my money on the First Ones. Of all the places on Etheria I know of, their influence has been the strongest here.” she said thoughtfully. They walked along the wide streets of the capital, covered with slabs of white stone.

“So Moonshadow is a pirate queen, right?” the silver-haired elf changed the subject.

“A pirate queen and a queen being a pirate are two separate issues...” she muttered to herself thoughtfully, but Ireanis continued her considerations.

“I once knew a pirate queen, a very aggressive woman. But since the old queen is alive, whether her daughter is the queen is an interesting question, Miss Daisy.”

She frowned. This was indeed a legal problem. Purely theoretically, Glimmer's coronation was illegal and all the decisions she issued had no legal force. This could cause problems in the future and Glimmer's enemies could take advantage of it... If she had any. She looked around. The atmosphere in the city was joyful, but she could see guards around, much more modern armed than those guarding her, keeping a watchful eye on everyone arriving for the festival. Perhaps it was a habit left over from the war, or a simple safety measure, but it could also mean fear of a real threat. She'll have to find out more about it... In due time.

They reached a large park almost impossible to distinguish from the forest. Here she and the silver-haired sorceress stopped and inhaled the pure Etherian air, absorbing the power with which it was imbued. At first she thought she had forgotten how great it felt, but then she realized it was something completely new. *It's thanks to you, Adora . Thanks to you destroying the Heart* she

thought. For a few moments they just stood in silence, with the trees rustling overhead. And then she heard the voice that brought her so much joy. She turned around abruptly and then she saw her. She stood there, dressed in civilian clothes in the colors of the order, but at her belt she had her sword, the new one that Rechiza was looking at. Now she realized that it was made of the same material as Eti's hand. Could this also be one of the First Ones' artifacts? This was getting more and more disturbing. But now, she couldn't think about it. There she was, with her golden hair and that beautiful smile illuminating her usually stern face. At first, her heart beat faster, filled with pure joy. The one who was so dear to her, for whom she did so much, for whom she killed, was here with her. And then her heart sank as she realized where she was. They were on Etheria, her planet, and in Brighmoon , the place where almost everyone she mentioned in her stories lived. She knew the truth about her, she even knew her damned name. She just didn't know that this was the planet she came from. That she had kept knowledge crucial to this mission from her. She had no idea what the Lord Admiral was doing, but he was clearly successful if she came here dressed like that... She had to do something quickly... Immediately.

“Good... Good to see you.” she said quietly. Something in her tone or face made the Lady of Blades worry, and she walked up to her and placed a hand on her shoulder.

“Is everything ok….” she didn't finish because a stone fist hit her from the side. Ireanis, she forgot about Ireanis. She looked at Ireanis, who was smiling with joy and pride.

“Ha, I saved you again... From someone you once betrayed, tried to kill or tortured.” she exclaimed in a happy voice. She took a deep breath so as not to attack the sorceress with fury and said, trying to contain her outburst of rage.

“This is Asindesa di Vir.” She realized that she was not sure whether the elven sorceress should know the true identity of the hell knight. “My friend from Carurystal.” she said, emphasizing the word friend.

“But in what sense that you said...” only after a while did the Elf realize what was going on.

“I told you I wasn't in love with anyone from my planet. – she approached the sorceress from the lost Golarion and added in a low voice.

“And I prefer that she doesn't find out where I really am from.” when she was sure that Ireanis wouldn't do anything stupid, she ran to Asindesa di Vri to make sure she was okay. The Hell Knight was just regaining consciousness. She looked fine, except for a bruise under her eye. As soon as she regained consciousness, Asidesa jumped to her feet and drew her sword, so she began to calm her down.

“You're in no danger, it was my friend Ireanis. She is a highly skilled war mage who hails from the lost Golarion. It was just an accident, she is really very alert.” she explained, pointing to the elf, who was smiling a bit goofily. Asindesa looked at her warily, but sheathed her weapon.

“Quite a painful misunderstanding, but I've witnessed worse.” she said and squeezed the silver-haired sorceress's hand very, very tightly, until she groaned painfully, and she smiled friendly and patted her on the back, until Ireanis almost fell over. “But congratulations on your training, not many would be able to take me down with one spell, even considering that I have no armor.” said the knight of hell.

“Armor?” the silver-haired wizard asked, surprised. She cursed inwardly, inwardly, but before she could say anything, Asindesa di Vir spoke.

“I'm a Hell knight... Although I'm on leave now.” explained the lady of the blades. Ireanis looked at her suspiciously, but then smiled and said.

“Oh, I knew some Hell Knights on Golarion. They were very... principled people... I would even say uncompromising. On old

Golarion, most of them lived in the thrice-cursed Cheliax... But enough about the past... I'll leave you to talk.” she said and hurried away from them with hurried steps. She watxged the silver-haired sorceress, wondering if she was starting to suspect something.

“Is she really from Lost Golarion?” Asindesa asked , breaking her from her thoughts. She shrugged.

“He definitely believes it. I have no idea what the truth is, but I know all too well that anything is possible in this world.” she said and looked at the woman who was so dear to her.

“I'm glad to see you.” Asindes gently touched her face . The knight smiled teasingly.

“Judging by your reaction, I wouldn't have guessed.”

She grimaced and began to explain.

“I was surprised. Besides, my companions don't know who we're working with, or even about the fleet.” she said in a low voice. She doubted Ireanis was eavesdropping on them, but she didn't want to risk it in this situation.” Besides, they have a quarrel with the Lord Admiral, a reasonable one in my opinion.”

“What do you mean?” Asindesa asked , concerned. She sighed and began to tell her what she had learned. About the civil war on Tarak, the support of Veskarium and the tragic end, and about Jantar having some unclear connections with Antares. Asindesa listened to her carefully, with full concentration. When she finished her story, the Lady of Blades replied slowly and thoughtfully.

“I've heard some rumors that people like that don't make a career without getting their hands dirty. However, I didn't expect it to be such a terrible story. However, I can believe it. Just look at the people around him. Lady Sorrowflame and especially Lady Ka are terrible women. Are you saying that Lady Ka is a clone? No one knows her past, but she is a psychopathic sadist. Her soldiers are a bunch of scums and thugs from a dark background. She keeps

them on a tight leash, brutally punishing them for their insubordination. She orders her own soldiers to be shot when they retreat without permission. And Lady Sorrowflame , she's... She's a dragon... A real dragon. Her body was transformed by numerous implants. In itself, it has the power of a small army, but that's not all. She is a necromancer, even a necrotechnician . He can create terrible monsters that are a combination of dead bodies and machines. It is rumored that it originates from the Lost Golarion. Her name there was Ashaq the Annihilator although I have no idea how much of it is true and how much is fantastic speculation. However, if what you say is true, then these two are just little devils in the service of a real archdevil." The knight of Hell rubbed her forehead. She herself sighed heavily, on Etheria dragons were considered creatures of myth and legend. Supposedly, the previous She-Ra was supposed to ride a dragon, but she considered it unlikely. But if Lady Sorrowflame was a real dragon, then it was even worse than she dared to imagine. E*very day the light around me darkens and the world becomes even bleaker*. She thought bitterly and asked Asindesa di Vir.

"Does the Lord Admiral intend to come to Etheria"? She deliberately didn't use the word attack, but Asindesa shook her head and said.

"I don't think so , although I can't be sure. The Lord Admiral does not share his plans even with his own subordinates, let alone with allies he does not trust, of which I am proud to say I count myself . So far, the operation is going well. We managed to liberate Taurus from the hands of the clones who do not recognize Horde Prime's defeat. The Lord Admiral made himself at home there. For now, he seems to be waiting for the reaction of the rest of the powers of the region, including the rulers of Etheria"

She frowned and looked Asindesa straight in the eyes.

"So why did you come here?"

The Lady of Blades looked at her tenderly and with love and said.

“For you, my dearest. To experience some happy moments with you.” and she kissed him.

Hoofy took them to a very nice, at least in his opinion, tailoring shop. Of course, he ignored her extremely important question and moved on with Lilka and Alatar, and Itel and Sparkling Paw entered the shop. She felt very stupid staying outside. Of course, she didn't envy them for their beautiful clothes and such nonsense, her desert coat might have been a bit threadbare, and maybe it deserved a little more washing and a few small patches, but it was suitable even for a royal wedding, and it smelled of her, she liked her scent very much . But as her friends entered, she felt as if she had been left out of some extremely important event that the two girls could share together. That's why she decided to sneak to the back of the shop. Of course, she wasn't supposed to peek on them, although she didn't know if there would be anything wrong with that. She had seen Itel naked and even made love to her more than once. Sparkling Paw had also seen her breasts, so maybe it should be mutual... But just because she had no intention of peek on them didn't mean she couldn't eavesdrop on them, that was something completely different. They had no reason to be angry with her. Besides, she had such sensitive hearing that she didn't have to eavesdrop on anyone, it was enough that she was standing close and everything could be heard. The tailoring shop had no cameras, no alarms, and no combat sentinel robots ready to tear intruders to shreds. In fact, the owners of this establishment should be grateful to her for showing their a reprehensible lack of safeguards against spies and assassins . Assassins! It was actually the perfect place to carry out an assassination attempt. If someone is naked in the dressing room, when attacked, they will be too embarrassed to defend themselves... So you can say that she wasn't eavesdropping at all, but was guarding her friends against the attackers! When she got quite close to the changing room, she froze and listened.

“Don't worry, I'm sure you'll be fine. You can fence, it's almost like dancing, isn't it? “ Sparkling Paw said.

“I can dance. In our village we danced, our life was not only focused on hugging trees or killing innocent animals. I heard both versions at school. It's just, you know... It was a long time ago and I've never danced at a ball or anything like that.” said Itel. She sounded embarrassed.

“Don't worry, no one will judge you here. It's not like school, I've never been to one, but I can imagine how it is, and I'm sure you remember how to dance. You don't forget things like that. Even I haven't forgotten.” she heard Sparkle Paw take a few rhythmic steps, but itel sighed heavily.

“It's not just about whether I can still dance. I… I don't know if I should. Since... Ever since Kesler fell, I have done everything to... To avenge my loved ones and everyone I have lost. That's why I came here, to get a weapon that will help defeat the Swarm once and for all. And now I'm going to a stupid princess dance for a stupid wedding while thousands of innocents are dying across the galaxy. I feel like I'm the one killing them myself. By dealing with such nonsense, instead of exploring this planet and finding a way to achieve victory, I accept this evil. I should be seeking knowledge about this Heart, but I'm trying on fucking dresses. I feel lousy.”

Itel fell silent, but Sparkle paw took a few quick steps. She probably hugged her… *Sparkle Paw and Itel hugging together… That's interesting.* She came closer, very curious, but then she heard a sound as if Itel was struggling or pushing Rosie away.

“Why are you like this! So nice! I'm always mean to you, I insult you, and you still comfort me. Why are you doing that.” Itel shouted, her voice breaking.

“It's just the way I am. I don't know why... But you're just mad at me because you're jealous of Eti.” Sparkle Paw said carefully.

“And I have no reason?” Itel's voice was innocently gentle. Eti held her breath waiting for the white-haired girl's answer.

“I... I like Eti.” she could almost hear Sparkle Paw blushing. She was beautiful when she blushed. There was silence, broken by Itel's growl.

“Eti, you could stop eavesdropping on us.”

“I'm not eavesdropping on you, I'm watching over you so that no Assassins murder you “ she explained without feeling embarrassed.

“What Fucking Assassins!” exclaimed the Elf.

“Very sneaky and a bit perverted...” she explained, slightly touched by her friend's lack of understanding. The Solarian sighed heavily and said.

“Just go away and wait outside, okay.”

She huffed offended but did as she was told, but before she left she heard Sparkle Paw talking

“And back to our conversation... You don't have to take the happiness of all of us on your shoulders, because you also deserve a few happy moments.”

Eti waited for her friends for almost an hour, keeping track of the time. What was this about trying on clothes? For her, clothes had to be, above all, thick, warm and cover as much of the body as possible. Or they might not have existed at all. She watched the passersby with boredom. At one point, the girls invited her in and showed her what they were wearing. Sparkle Paw chose a light blue dress that beautifully highlighted the color of her eyes. Itel wore an orange-red strapless dress. She felt herself blushing at the sight. Finally, they packed the ordered outfits and went outside the store. Her friends seemed happy… Even Itel.

“Look what a nice earring I bought. Miss Deer helped me choose one that I can wear even though I have almost no ears.” Sparkle

Paw pointed to a fancy earring in the shape of a white rose.

“I see that the shopping issue is already behind you.” she heard Grimmy's voice . There was a note of joy in it, something completely inappropriate for this woman. She turned around and raised an eyebrow, surprised by what she saw. The sorceress smiled slightly at them, and next to her stood a tall and muscular woman with golden hair. She had acid burn marks on her face, and a sword that looked disturbingly familiar at her belt. The woman looked no less basic than Grimmy, but she smiled warmly, and, even more strangely, she was holding hands with the dark sorceress, regardless of the fact that the hand shimmered slightly as it broke the illusory disguise. What does this place do to people?

“Hey Grimmy, Hey Razor. Well, Itel and Sparky Paw bought some clothes for the party, and actually, Grimmy, you should buy something for yourself too, because if you'll excuse me, you look like you're going to the funeral of someone you like?”

“Razor? Gloomy?” the golden-haired woman asked, clearly confused.

“Eti has a habit of giving others new names.” she explained to her… friend, and then turned to Eti. “Unfortunately, due to my… unusual situation, I do not want to use the services of a tailor, but I have appropriate clothes with me. This is my friend Asindesa, the Lady of Blades from the Order of the Eclipse. We met on Carurystal, and now, to my surprise, she appeared on Etheria. Now we would like to spend some time together. I hope you don't mess anything up along the way.

Sparkle Paw and Itel shook their heads vehemently, and the two women went away, leaving them alone.

“But she is with the Hell Knight.” said Rosie in disbelief.

“Seriously, are you surprised? Look how well they fit together ...” said Eti, pointing to the women leaving.

Alatar listened to Swiftwind telling them about his adventures with Adora She- Ra and what was planned for the Victory Day celebrations. In the meantime, Lilka stared at him as if enchanted and fed him with fruit bought from the sellers she met, and at the same time, Toshi, apparently offended by the lack of attention from her mistress, she bit the aricorn's horn and mane, and when the aricorn, absorbed in the monologue, did not pay attention to him, he lay down on his shoulder. Dragonkin and bit his neck, squeaking sadly. After an hour of monologue, Swiftwind began to tell them about the occupation and casually mentioned the Heart of Etheri. Alatar's heart began to beat faster. Now he has a chance to make a good impression on Itel. The elf will definitely look at him differently when he is the first to provide her with information about this artifact.

“And about this Heart of Etheria, so what did you do with it? Where is it located?” He asked. The mount became confused and said.

“Well, it would be difficult to hide it, it was quite large... in fact, it was all of Etheria. Among other things... Well, he's gone. It's a scary story, but it had a happy ending! - and he began to tell them about the end of the war with the Etherian Horde, what the Queen had done when she had her back against the wall, and finally about the last battle during which Horde Prime was defeated . And how Adora destroyed the weapon, releasing the magic back into the universe.

“Great story, isn't it?” Adora's mount asked at the end. Alatar nodded cautiously and replied.

“Yes, really amazing... I think it's time for us... We have to meet our friends now.” He said and left, dragging Lilka behind him.

Right after disconnecting from the magical steed, they sat by the fountain. Itel stared at the sky where the moons floated, seemingly listening to the sound of the fountain. But he knew her well enough to know that she was angry and sad at the same time

“You know, Itel, we can just go back to the original plan.” he started, but the Elf interrupted him.

“NO!” she turned to them and glared at them, then said. “Do you really believe them? In these lies they spread? No normal person would get rid of such a weapon. They probably deactivated it and hid the activation codes or something like that somewhere.” she looked at Brightmoon Castle . – And we will get them back today.”

“I'll just do one thing.” Eti said, and for a moment he had the impression that she was embarrassed... But he didn't believe it... Eti wasn't ashamed.

A few minutes later, Eti knocked on the door of the tailor's shop. A pretty deer girl opened the door and smiled at her.

“Oh, it's you. Are you friends with Rosie and Itel? Do you also want to buy an outfit for the festival” she asked in a cheerful tone. She nodded and said.

“Yes, only in my case there may be a problem.” she said shyly. The seamstress looked at her with sympathy.

“Oh, we served war victims many times. We have special dresses, and if you think you need it, my brother can make you a special mask. He has equipment straight from Icarus.

“This is a slightly different situation.” she said and went inside, then uncovered her face. The seamstress and her partner gasped and widened their eyes. She almost smiled at the sight.

“I need an outfit, but it has to be different than what she wear... that Catra wears. And not a word to anyone... It's supposed to be a surprise...”

Council

„How did they left the Alliance!” she shouted, absolutely furious.

„Well, normally... They sent declarations of abandoning the Alliance. In the document establishing the Alliance, created, I would like to remind you, by your parents, there is a provision stating that you can withdraw from the Alliance membership at any time by sending a simple declaration. The only condition was that no battle could be taking place at that moment. Your parents also defined the term Battle, but it doesn't matter because I'm pretty sure there isn't one going on right now.” said High Minister Shou . She was an otter person who had held this position since her mother's time. In fact, Quen Angela was served by her mother, father and great-grandfather, and the ruler of Brightmoon must have really appreciated the services of this family. After the Galactic Horde was defeated, it was decided that the title of Prime Minister had a bad connotation, so he was renamed High Minister. She was actually quite fond of Shou, who helped raise her after she lost her father. She was her teacher and gave her all her knowledge, which was very boring she must have added. She spoke with an accent very similar to her mother's, which, combined with the judgmental look in her eyes, made her feel tempted to teleport to her room whenever she looked at her.

„What does Frosta say? Did she say anything?” She asked with a bit of hope in her voice. She liked the Ice Princess, and younger girl admired her. She certainly wouldn't agree to something like that. All they have to do is talk and everything will be clear.

Shou cleared her throat significantly and began to explain.

„They declared themselves the People's Republic of Snow. It is doubtful that Frosty's consent , or lack thereof, made any difference. Moreover, a few moments ago news reached us that Grand Marshal Catra had taken Princess Frosta aboard a vehicle

belonging to Princess Netossa and was going to take her to their manor... Then they would take Princess Entrapta and Mr. Lance and Mr. George to them to their homes. But first they will bring Adora She” Ra , the princess of power, to Brightmoon, because she has very important news for the queen.

She blinked several times in surprise.

„Is Adora here? When did she come here? Are Princesses Scorpia and Perfuma here? What is this important news?” she bombarded the high minister with questions. The otter person turned up her nose in disapproval and said.

„ I don't know the answer to any of your questions, my queen. I'm just repeating to you what came to me. If you want to find out more, you will either have to ask the former chancellor in person or wait a while. If you want to do the former, I politely suggest putting on warmer clothes.”

For a moment she really was going to do that. Teleport to the Chancellor and yell at him for daring to destroy the alliance they had worked so hard to build. For whom they sacrificed so much, but thanks to whom they managed to achieve victory. Just... What would she do if he didn't listen to her? She couldn't rule with threats and intimidation... She couldn't, could she? She plopped down on the chair and Bow put a hand on her shoulder. She stroked it tenderly, but then John Killthem, ambassador from Bellum, spoke up.

„If I could speak, and I can, because I am present at this meeting.” His voice was muffled by the gas mask he wore, but she could still hear he radiated cheerfulness. “I could suggest mild retaliatory action using several nuclear warheads.”

There was silence as everyone present stared speechlessly at the ambassador.

„We will not bomb Kingdom of Snow„ she growled menacingly, glaring at the short person in military clothing who replied

undeterred.

„I'm not talking about bombing the Kingdom of Snow. Its Annihilation would be definitely overkill.” he laughed merrly like Grandpa Moon from fairy tales. "We'll just bomb one small settlement and then the next, gradually escalating the conflict, unless they surrender and hand over the rebellion leaders so we can publicly execute them."

There was silence again, which was finally broken by her fiancé, speaking in a hard voice

„This is not the way we on Etheri resolve conflicts. Not doing war crimes.”

„There are no war crimes if you win the war.” John explained, as if he were quoting a popular proverb.

„Would you surrender if someone bombed you?” her fiancé replied. The ambassador thought for a moment and said.

„Good point.”

She rubbed her temples, feeling a growing headache. She had been in pain a lot lately, and she often felt nauseous in the mornings. She should probably go to doctor...

„Tomorrow I will demand an explanation from the chancellor or whatever his name is now. I want to hear everything from Catra and Adora first. And Frosta . First of all, Frosta. Anything else.”

Shou nodded and General Jocelyn and Astromaster Onyx Sky of Icarus stood up and the seccond person spoke.

„ We have other, more disturbing news.” the voice of the person from Icarus was strong and resonant. The arrived here right after the end of the war and was engaged in communication with other planets. They where much more communicative than the former ruler of Dryl and didn't get distracted so easily, so she actually put them in charge of interplanetary diplomacy.

„What can be more disturbing than losing one of our Alliance members?” she shouted indignantly, getting up from the chair again

„Taurus has been conquered.” Onyx Sky said and the entire Council Hall fell silent. Not as full of indignation as when Ambassador Bellum spoke, but full of fear and anxiety

„What happened... Was it Horde Ultimate? He finally decided to get off his ass and attack, or did these fucked up brothers decide to attack!?” she shouted d after a while, feeling fear turn into rage. Onyx Sky shook her head.

„None of them. It's someone from the outside. They introduce themselves as the Research and Exploration Fleet and claim to have come here from the Pact Worlds and Veskarium on a stabilization mission, whatever that may be. From what I understand , they managed to gain control of Taurus in less than a week, although I must also note that the planet was largely controlled by a local rebellion. They say they came here because they were attacked, although I don't know much more”

She looked at them feeling numb. She didn't believe there was anything beyond Prime's empire. She wanted his words to be true, that he had conquered the entire universe. Now, in an instant, it had become so much greater, immeasurable, just as Entrapta had said. Not only immeasurable, but full of powers whose true purposes they did not know. And it was she, as the queen of Etheria and the leader of the emerging Galactic Alliance, who had to face it for the good of her subjects. She sighed and narrowed her eyes. Then she felt Bow place a hand on her shoulder. She wasn't alone. She still had those she loved, her friends, with her. He'll definitely be able to handle them. She looked at the others. Jocelyn looked unfazed, as she had been throughout the war. She has always been a tough commander, having led the Brightmoon military for as long as she could remember, though Catra took over most of her responsibilities. In fact, she had been a general for as long as almost anyone could remember, because as a Saihe she was long-lived. Her mother witnessed Queen Angela taking

the throne. She was mysterious and spent her last years with her daughter. She has reportedly been spending more and more time with Onyks Sky recently, but hasn't delved into the rumors. Shou looked terrified. She wasn't surprised. She spent almost her entire life on a planet at war and even helped rule it. She hoped that she would finally find peace. Now it turned out that a new, completely unknown threat had arrived. Castaspella and the other princesses were not here. These were only the ambassadors of Eridani and Aquarius. The first was a quiet and polite winged woman with beautiful golden hair who seemed to have a bit of a crush on her as well, named Tuo. She was probably the empress's sister, though out of wedlock, whatever that meant. Aquarius's ambassador was a short green-skinned woman with a bald head and big ears named Dayiuk . Despite its name, her planet was almost entirely covered in glass deserts, although it was not real glass, but rather strangely crystallized water. According to Entrapta, these were once oceans, although the inventor has never been to this planet. Of all the places in Prime's empire that they knew of, it was there that the memory of First One's culture survived the best. Only, unlike on Etheria, they were not treated as great progenitors who brought civilization with them, but as conquerors who destroyed their world. So when the Horde arrived and its ruler claimed that he had murdered this ancient race, they hailed him as a Hero, or as they claimed, a prophet... At least until he began to impose his tyrannical rule... Still, of all the planets that wanted to join planned Alliance, most of the Horde Prime supporters remained there, and sometimes very fanatical ones. Only John Killthem seemed pleased.

„So your wedding... Victory Day will be canceled?" Tuo asked in a shy voice and blushed. She resisted the urge to roll her eyes. Such shyness could be as charming as it was irritating

„That wouldn't be a good idea; „ Shou said in a serious tone, having regained her composure. "We have all been preparing for this event for a good six months, if not more. All inhabitants of Etheria and nearby planets will be able to celebrate not only the wedding, but also the end of the war that has cost us all so much. This would lead to a worsening of moods in all kingdoms. There is

another thing. During all these terrible years of war, we never canceled festivities, parties and festivals, even when we were threatened by Horde troops. If we cancel the celebration now, we will admit that this threat is more terrible than the one they have faced for thirty years, perhaps even as terrible as the Galactic Horde. This would be contrary to everything we believe in, inconsistent with the spirit dormant in the hearts of the inhabitants of our planet!" she hit the table top with her small fist and then suddenly looked at the others with surprise, as if she was surprised by her outburst and looked down. She smiled warmly at the high minister and teleported next to her.

„These were wonderful words, High Minister. We cannot let fear rule our lives and take away the joy of celebration. Besides... We don't know if this Fleet has hostile intentions towards us. We only know that they clashed with Prime's loyalists, with whom we have fought many times over the past five years. Perhaps they are not a threat, but potential friends. Allies who will help us defend against Horde Ultimate and the Heavenly Brothers." When she said this, she teleported from one of the people present in the council room to another. Tua turned beet red as soon as she was next to her. "There is a chance for us to establish relations with the rest of the galaxy. They made friendships that... Well, which are what we value the most." when it ended, everyone present started applauding, and the ambassador from Bellum called out.

„The queen talks well! Let's form an alliance with this fleet so that we can bring the conflagration of war to the homes of our enemies!"

Again, everyone present looked at John in disbelief.

„The conflagration of war is not quite what I thought." she said carefully.

Over the next few hours, they agreed that they would not declare a state of emergency or notify the general population of the

planet, but would quietly warn the space fleet and all concerned services of the potential threat. Then they moved on to some less important issues. Tuo happily informed her that Castaspella had agreed to the masquerade ball. She sighed as she heard her exclamation of delight. Catra made it very clear that she didn't want masks at her wedding, which she understood perfectly. It will be very awkward to find out that one of her few wishes for her wedding has been simply ignored, not to mention the hassle of having to make such last-minute changes. She just hoped it wasn't malice on Aunt Casta's part. After she approved the idea of serving a choux pastry cake at the wedding, Catra really liked all the creamy custards. After the entire session, she felt very tired. She teleported out the door, but still let Bow lead her away. She needed the closeness of another person now. This day didn't seem to be that difficult at morning. She got up in the morning with the belief that it would be another day of crazy wedding preparations, until suddenly she learned about the collapse of Alliances, at least partial, and then the specter of another war hung over Etheria. Was this how her mother felt, on the eve of the battle during which she lost her father... No, she knew the risk then... It was like when she found Adora, and the Sword... If she had left a few moments later, or if she had not quarreled with my mother, everything would be different. They would live in another world, or perhaps another universe.

„You know, Bow, I feel like it used to be easier. We could just fight the Horde, we didn't have to think about anything else. It was that simple. It was enough, as Frosta said, to punch the bad guys in the face.”

They laughed, but then Bow turned serious and said.

„ It wasn't easier, maybe just simpler... Do you remember how many times we risked our lives by rushing into battle? How many times have we been afraid of what the next day will bring? And the next morning, everything hurt.” he hugged her tightly, but she looked at him with furrowed eyebrows.

„I thought you'd have better memories of all this.”

He laughed warmly.

„Because I have, but I also remember that it wasn't easy. I remember how I lost you. How I was almost sure I would never see you again. It's not a good memory. Fortunately, now I always have you with me.” he kissed her. For a moment she felt pure happiness spreading through her body, but then she remembered everything she had heard during the Council and felt all the joy drain from her.

„But now it may all come back. We may have to fight for freedom again.

Her almost-husband hugged her tightly.

„And just now you said that you miss the war times.” he said, smiling, and when she gave him a sharp look, he added. “I'm sure everything will work out somehow. We must be vigilant, but we cannot be afraid of the shadows. Whoever these non-Imperial visitors are, they're certainly not as bad as Horde Prime or Shadow Weaver.”

She frowned. Unlike Catra and Adora, no she could hate the dark sorceress so much, even after learning that she had sent her father to Beast Island. Much of what she was able to do, especially in the field of sorcery, but not only, was due to her. She was wise and had knowledge beyond anything other sorcerers of the Mystacor knew. There was a bit of goodness in her that Horde Prime was deprived of. Still, she was glad she died. She would have to be judged, and she didn't want to do that, especially since Shadow Weaver wouldn't accept the verdict with as much humility as Hordak. She sighed, there was no point in thinking about that damned woman. The dead stay dead. She wasn't sure what to make of Catra's story about the non-dead in Mystacor, but she didn't believe the dark sorceress was capable of returning… and even if she was, she wouldn't be stupid enough to return to Etheria. The only thing waiting for her here was the hatred she had earned. She sighed, she had other, much more important problems.

„I'm worried about what happened in Frosta's Kingdom. In her country she always had to be strong, she could never show weakness. We didn't remember this because most of the time we met her outside her own country, where she could be herself, cheerful and feisty Frosta. But we didn't see that when she returned home she had to deal with the same problems as everyone else, and on top of that she had to prove that even though she was so young, she was fit to be a ruler. It's kind of our fault that she lost her throne."

Bow shook his head.

„Don't blame yourself. It's all Lonnie's doing. She must have had a hand in it from the very beginning. Since the end of the war, she has wanted to deprive you and the other princesses of power." he said in a sharp tone. He hadn't liked Lonnie since Frosta's Ball. She didn't really know her herself. She only knew that she was Adora's friend, but not Catra's, when she still lived in the Horde. They met several times during the war, mostly in combat, but after she got Etheria out of Despondos, they never spoke to each other. Comrade General, as she was now called, did not respond to requests to establish diplomatic contacts. At first she believed that they would eventually come to an agreement with the People's Rebellion, but now.

„It all started much earlier. Sometimes I think Etheria doesn't need princesses anymore." she sighed, but her fiancé hugged her tightly and said.

„Do not say that! You are wonderful." he kissed her and added. "We all saved Etheria, it's true, but princesses have always ruled Etheria. Just ask my dads. By the way, I still can't believe they left the library and went on an adventure. We led them astray."

They laughed happily.

„Go to sleep, my dear, I still have to sign a few documents today and make the final corrections to the anniversary celebration." she kissed him and moved to the Fireplace Room. But the warm,

fatigue, and spiced wine soon overcame her, and she didn't even notice Bow laying her down on the sofa and covering her with a blanket.

Heist

„Eti, but are you even listening to me?” Itel shot the cat girl an angry look. “Even Rosie seems more focused on what I'm trying to tell you, not to mention Lilka. She writes down everything I said.” she pointed to Lilka, who was sitting leaning over a sheet of paper.

„Actually, Lilka draws horses and giant flying foxes. And I don't have a problem with focusing, I just don't understand why we do it...” Rosie said and added. „I'm not sure why it occurred to you to break into Brightmoon Castle ... We could have just talked to the queen or something. Not all people lie.” she explained, hoping that Itel wouldn't be mad at her. The elf was very decisive when it came to matters she cared about. The green-haired girl scowled at her, and for a moment she felt like she wanted to say something very unpleasant, but then she thought better of it and shook her head.

„Listen, Rosie, we can't count on the good will of strangers in such matters. Not when state secrets and ancient mysteries are involved. Maybe this Adora and the rest were nice, but when it comes down to it, everyone cares about their own people first. We can't trust them, we can't trust anyone except ourselves. Not when the stakes are so high.” Said the Elf. There was something feverish in her white-free eyes, not anger, but something like hunger. She wasn't entirely sure what it might be that she wanted, but she clearly hoped to find it in Brightmoon.

They talked in the forest surrounding the city of Brightmoon, because Itel was afraid that Mr. Ilemshaw would overhear them. She didn't like the fact that they were hiding something from Wrongdak, Mr. Ilemshaw and, above all, Miss Daisy... Especially the latter, she felt sorry for cheating her. She had absolutely no idea what to think of this woman anymore, but she couldn't be all bad if she had a girlfriend. Bad people don't fall in love... Of

course, this Asindesa was a Hell Knight, she was afraid of Hell Knights because she had heard many terrible stories about them. Someone who dealt with the powers of hell must have been very scary, although this woman didn't look that bad. She seemed quite nice, she didn't look like she wanted to bring about ultimate order with fire and sword. Well, about that sword. It seemed familiar to her, as did the symbols, as if she had read about it before or seen it in pictures. She didn't like it, in fact it even scared her. What connection could she have with all this? This planet, the First Ones, poor Heart Gift, with this sword? She doesn't know what this woman's order does, although she recognized the symbol of the Order of Eclipse, but she didn't want them to come here to Etheria and destroy everything... Although it wouldn't be that easy, she saw what power Adora and the other princesses had... They defeated Horde PrimeHorde 1). Hell Knights were no problem for them... But Eti was right about one thing, they really fit together perfectly.

She just… didn't want to get into trouble again… and breaking into the castle was clearly getting into trouble. She just didn't want to seem like... a coward? Ball and chain... Someone who bothers you with his stubbornness.

„Itel, do you know that we can really ask about this heart, at most they won't tell us anything. "Eti suddenly interjected. The elf looked at her in surprise, but then pursed her lips tightly and spoke slowly.

„How do you imagine it? We can't just march into the throne room."

Eti tilted her head back as if she was seriously considering and said

"Why wouldn't we be able to? All we have to do is do this." she took a few exaggerated steps. Itel gritted her teeth furiously.

„Could you act like an adult for a moment and not play the dumb like in a comedy for idiots?"

Eti looked at them, apologized with her beautiful cat eyes, does the other one also have such beautiful eyes in real life, and said.

„But seriously, we can do it. The Blonde... Adora likes us, and she seem like a very... honest person, not someone who has any secrets. And then there's that talkative horse. And if necessary... I can show them... Show them what I look like and then they'll let me in... I'd rather not do it, but if necessary, I will."

Everyone looked at the cat girl in surprise. No one expected such a declaration from her. Finally, Itel spoke in a much softer voice than before.

„Eti... you have always been the one who is the first to embark on all crazy adventures... The one who is never afraid of anything."

„I'm not afraid. You know I can't." Eti interrupted. In the golden eyes of the cat-like girl, Rosie saw pain „But it's really not wise. We don't have any plan, we don't even know the layout of the castle, and we don't even know what we're actually looking for. We'll get there withot idea what we are doing!"

„Sometimes in war you have to improvise." replied the Elf, looking at Eti seriously.

„This is not the war Itel." replied the cat girl, wagging her tail slightly.

„For me is!" Itel punched the ground. The two girls stared at each other for a moment until the scout closed her eyes.

„Fine, we'll do what you want, Itel, but I have one condition. This time we won't hurt anyone. I know I'm always the first to use violence, the one who hurts even my friends... Even the ones I love... This time I want it to be different... Because this place is different Itel."

The elf thought about Eti's words for some time, although according to Rosie, Eti was right, there was no need to use

violence. She didn't want to hurt anyone either. Finally, Itel nodded.

„Fine, we won't hurt anyone. Unless one of them starts first.”

Brightmoon Castle looked even more beautiful up close, it was truly like something out of a fairy tale. He even had an enchanted queen. Actually, this Glimmer looked a bit like a fairy queen. Although she had wings like an angel, they were actually a bit similar to Captain Moonshadow's, which was a bit strange. But she was definitely beautiful, although not as beautiful as Eti... It mean, Eti was very pretty, but Itel... Ugh, all four of them would definitely be friends... And Lilka and Alatar, and Wrongdak was already her friend.

Only now they were going to break into her castle. She hoped that she wouldn't be caught, because then the queen would definitely be offended at them and throw them into a dungeon full of rats, or worse, make them work off their crimes by serving the local equivalent of Dr. Quin. The problem was that she had absolutely no idea about burglaries. She had never even stolen anything, as far as she could remember. This observatory does not count because it was abandoned. Fortunately, her friends seemed to have a surprising amount of experience in these matters, which should have worried her, but in this case it was a good thing.

They tied scarves around their faces and, just in case, Lilka painted Orc war paint on their faces, although she seriously doubted whether the red-haired girl had any idea about Orc war paint, but it had to be admitted that it was really difficult to recognize them under these paintings. They couldn't come nearby in the ship because of Mr. Ilemshaw. Fortunately, Miss Daisy was on a date, she didn't want to imagine how the hell knights' dates were like, and Wrongdak decided that he would walk around the city and see what had changed. What Ireanis was doing, she had no idea, but it was a good thing that all responsible adults were busy now, at least for Itel…

First they had to climb the walls, which was surprisingly easy, because only Lilka had to climb the rope, Alatar and Itel simply flew up, Eti climbed do wall walk and she... got to the top thanks to long jumps, although she had the impression that she could also fly up. The sky above them was covered with stars, although the moons also provided some light, so it was surprisingly bright for a night. Itel didn't like it very much, but not enough to postpone the whole thing.

They found themselves in a wide corridor, lightly lit by crystal lamps, and the walls were covered with similar murals to the ones in the Heart Gift sanctuary, although these were somehow less majestic, but they were still pretty, they seemed more friendly, a little warmer. Overall, it was as beautiful as she had expected. Together with Itel and Eti, they moved ahead. This time, the shooter did not take her rifle or pistol with her, only stun and smoke grenades. At first she thought there were no guards here, but then Eti warned them to be quiet and a pair of guards passed them. They looked dignified and a little scary, but compared to the Azlanti they didn't look modern. They were armed with long halberds tipped with what seemed to be capable to electrocuting, and had armor that looked like modern armor with traditional cloaks over it. However, she felt like she and her friends were much better equipped. This time she didn't take her gloves with her so as not to lose or damage them. If anything, Eti could translate everything.

The guards passed by without paying any attention to them. They were having an intense conversation about some Frosta and the kingdom of Snow. They were really absorbed.

„Alatar says we need to look for a communication hub, or even a terminal. Probably both will be easily accessible, because the locals don't seem paranoid.” Eti said, but itel just snorted.

Finally, they reached a corridor that was especially densely covered with murals. You entered a large, unguarded hall. There were a lot of high chairs inside, which she didn't think looked very

comfortable. In the middle was a table that would make Alatar smile with all his teeth.

„I think it has a built-in computer... I secretly copied the hacking program.” Dragonkin explained and walked over to the device and started tinkering with it. Rosie didn't know anything about computers, so she started looking around the room. She saw murals on the walls and started looking at them. There were a lot of them here and they represented different people, probably important to Brightmoon or perhaps all of Etheria. One caught her attention in particular. He was right in the middle, as if in a place of honor. It depicted a tall, winged woman standing behind a shorter, bearded man. It reminded her of something. After a while, she realized who it was representing.

„Listen, I think these are Mikah and Captain Moonshadow.„ she said, but only then she realized that she wasn't wearing gloves, so she quickly turned around so that Eti could translate her words, but suddenly she bumped into a pedestal, which fell and hit another pedestal. and another. She may not have heard the noise she made, but she felt a tremble as if the lock were about to collapse. Her friends looked at her with fear on their faces.

„Sorry.” she said in sign language.

"Deaf Idiot" Itel said, her face contorted with fury, but Eti interjected.

„Leave her alone, it can happen to anyone.”

Solarian she uttered a particularly nasty elven curse that her glasses couldn't translate, then turned to Alatar.

„How's your hacking going?”

Dragonkin tilted his head as if considering something and said.

„This is kind of weird. As if they had no security. Either they are very trusting or it is some kind of trap.”

„It's definitely a trap. Check three times before you do anything. Itel growled at him.” Eti and Rosie, check if we summoned anyone when we did this mess.” she said and Eti nodded and together they moved towards the door. It was quiet in the corridor for now, they didn't see anyone. Then suddenly she felt something strange, like a flash of power that gave her a strange taste in her mouth… like strawberry marshmallows. Her glasses told her " Zap"

A strange noise woke her up. She got to her feet and took a fighting stance. For a moment she thought the Horde was attacking and they had to fight off their assault together, but when she looked around she realized she was in her Fireplace Room. It was still pleasantly warm, although the fire was already dying down, and there were papers and a half-finished carafe of wine on the table. Bow must have put her on the sofa when she fell asleep at work and she didn't even wake up. He was so caring… But the thud was real. It was coming from downstairs, from the council room, where there was a computer table on which they displayed strategic plans during the war. The room was perfectly soundproofed, so you couldn't hear anything that was said there... Apart from the Fireplace Room, it seemed that one of the architects building the castle had some sinister cunning. However, there was no time to consider the intentions of the ancient builders. Someone had broken into her castle and only she was aware of it. She could call the guards, they would certainly be able to deal with any threat, well almost any, but she was Glimmer, the warrior queen. A Sorcerer Queen who was trained by Mikach and... Shadow Weaver, the most talented sorcerers in all of Etheria . She couldn't just run for help for any reason. I'm sure she'll be fine on her own. And besides, as she told Bow, she kind of missed the old days. She smiled smugly and teleported downstairs.

She saw five people in the Council Room. Four of them looked normal and one was huge and had wings and a tail. She couldn't say much more about them because they had scarves on their faces. She put her arms around her and said.

„I think I caught someone here.” she smiled cheekily, and then the hands of one of these people lit up and a clenched fist flew towards her and she saw all the stars.

She woke up when she felt someone lifting her eyelid.

„Hey Pretty one. Don't have brain damage? Sparkle Paw will be sorry” said the person who was leaning over her. She had a strange mask on her face and goggles over her eyes. She wagged her tail, similar to Catra's tail, nervously. Her right arm was made of a strange metal, a bit like the Tallstar prosthetic but still a bit more... ancient? As if cast from one piece of metal. She pointed with her tail at a person standing behind who wore strange glasses and was wringing her hands as if in despair. Apart from her, there was also a green-haired person radiating irritation, a figure with red braids wearing a poncho, and then there was this huge winged person. She felt a bit strange, her head and face hurt, it must have been a really powerful blow, but there was something else that she couldn't define. She shook her head to clear her mind of the daze and said.

„What? Who are you?” she asked, still a bit unconscious.

„ Well, I am myself, who else could I be? Are you sure you don't have brain damage? I think I could trepanate the skull...„ said the person with the metal hand, and the winged one added.

„ Eti, "I think I can" is not a good recommendation to perform medical procedures.”

„Maybe you could focus on hacking instead of wagging your tongue?” the green-haired girl growled angrily. Now she remembered everything. Breaking into her castle! How dare they! She jumped to her feet, clenched her fists ready to fight, and screamed.

„Excuse me, but what are you doing in my castle?”

The girl in the goggles turned her head to the side and said in a strangely dull voice.

„Well, we're breaking into the castle, you can't see? My friend wanted to know something about this heart Etheria. Oh yes, you can help us, pretty one. You see, my friend thinks you're lying about ruining Etheria's heart, but I'm not so sure.

She blinked. They were looking for Heart of Etheria! Why? Well, of course, they wanted to take control of the most terrible weapon in the Galaxy. This was getting serious... With a quick movement, she cast a stunning spell and grabbed the girl with the metal arm by the arm and teleported to the nearest guardhouse...

Only to find yourself in the hallway. She looked around confused. Something was wrong. Once in space, when she was Horde Prime's prisoner, she couldn't use magic at all, but now her teleportation just didn't work properly. It was a bit like the first time she visited Castle Crypto or... when Shadow Weaver trapped her. She guess, it was because of that punch from that other person. Did she really have brain damage? She didn't have time to think about it, because the girl she grabbed screamed.

„Let me go! No one is allowed to touch me. No one!” And she started struggling with it. She tried to hit her on the head with a metal hand, but she managed to avoid the blow, but the girl caught her around the waist with her strong legs, although she hardly used her left hand. This actually worked to her advantage, because she didn't have to hold her herself so she could teleport her... Except her teleporters didn't work... First she moved to the garden, then to the roof of the tower, and finally to the fountain. That girl fought great and was stronger than her. At some point during the struggle, her face was uncovered and she gasped for air. This girl… looked almost like Catra. Her opponent frowned and bit her hand. Her teeth were also as sharp as Catra's. She screamed in pain and moved to the safest place she knew, her bedroom.

As soon as she got there, she saw Bow , who was already wearing a nightgown, but he didn't look sleepy because he immediately jumped to his feet and drew his bow.

„Shoot it with a sticky arrow!” she exclaimed. She didn't have to tell her twice, Bow chose the arrow and pulled back the string, while she threw the magic missile at the girl so as not to hurt her. The arrow hit the burglar, immobilizing her for a moment, and then she began to cast a protective spell that trapped her in a protective circle. Then the girl began to look around with fear in her golden eyes with blue dots. Now she was completely sure that this girl, despite her painted face, was very similar to Catra. Not as a representative of the same people, but as a close relative.

„Let me out of here! You can't imprison me!” she screamed. There was panic in her voice.

„Glimmer, where did you get the new Catra?” Bow asked with surprise.

„Can you believe, she wanted to break into our castle?” she asked her fiancé, and he nodded with full understanding.

„It seems very... fitting, actually.” said the techmaster, and then Brother Blade looked inside. „ Is everything OK? “ he asked, and then he saw the prisoner and his eyes widened.

„Yes, we have everything under control, she said, trying to sound as queenly as possible. The clone nodded and added.

Grand Marshal Catra and Princess of Power Adora have just entered Brightmoon City's airspace and will be here soon.=.

„That's great, because there's someone here she'd like to meet.” she said, wondering if her news would beat the news brought by Catra .

Faith, Love and Anxiety

Mr. Ilemshaw was actually very pleased with all that progress. His species had never been interested in this sort of thing. Most of the Eldritch races did not develop technology like the younger races. They didn't need a lot of equipment. They were much more physically fit and intellectually superior to most computers. They lived extremely long lives, being virtually immortal unless killed. They did not possess the desires and fears of ordinary mortals, although they, the Alghollthu, were somewhat more like them in this respect. They had no need for entertainment or religion, they saw the world simply as it was. Many of them had psionic and sometimes magical powers. So they invented machines only when they really needed them. Most often, they were related to research, exploration or war. They would never have invented things like Infonet or feedback neural interface, thanks to which there was no need to leave the ship. In a sense, this pursuit of comfort allowed them to evolve much faster than the eldritch races that viewed them as mere curiosities, barely conscious creatures, suitable as slaves, guinea pigs, or snacks. Yes, the power of the ancient races faded, or perhaps rather dimmed as their younger successors took their place... even if only temporarily. Young races came and went, like the waves of the sea hitting granite rocks. However, it was impossible to forget that the waves were crushing the rock... That's exactly what happened here. The First Ones, an ancient civilization for some and the nouveau riche for others... Beings who, in their pride, wanted to annihilate the entire universe, surpassing even the ancient Azlanti who almost killed life on the lost Golarion... And it was said that his species was vile. Of course, they also helped significantly in all this.

He himself knew little about such matters. He was born during the Gap and remembered virtually nothing of his long existence, apart from certain facts, such as the fact that he was an outcast, a dissenter from his race. He guessed why. He was a misfit...

someone with a distorted psyche, because he felt... friendship, compassion and loyalty. This was alien to his species, and even such rational beings did not tolerate difference... not this kind of difference... That's why he didn't miss his kin. He felt good among the Bina’s crew, those hurting and suffering beings who were not broken and tried to make a life for themselves in this sad and indifferent universe. Yes, he liked them and tried to take care of them, even when they didn't want him to... it was enough to just go unnoticed, and it was easy to go unnoticed when you lived in a tank inside the ship. And here they came back to technology.

He didn't eavesdrop on the crew members or spy on them, although he wasn't interested in their physiognomy. He understood what privacy was and was able to respect it. He had his own ways to obtain the necessary information. Few people realized how sensitive ordinary scanners are, at least in the hands, although in his case they were more like tentacles, someone who knows how to use them properly.

His new passengers were a good example. The Verthani, the Warper, the Mercenary , and the Scientist were not very interesting, except for the hunter's eyes, which were a form of implant he had never seen before, but the rest was a mystery even to him, even though he considered himself a scholar.

Let's start with Lady Cala. She certainly wasn't human, which wasn't strange in itself, after all, many so”called pure”blooded people, even among the Azlanti aristocracy, had some inhuman blood in them. Usually elven or orc blood, but surprisingly often also planotouched blood such as Tieflings. All you had to do was look hard enough. But Lady Cala was something else entirely. Both completely alien to most inhabitants of the galaxy, but something well known, and very closelly reated to their species. Something that did exist not only in the visible part of the universe. Something that aroused fear even in such inhuman beings as Mi-Go. He considered telling the truth to his friends, but feared the repercussions. Such a nefarious creature could want to kill everyone and probably succeed, especially if Miss Daisy helped

her.

The elf was a separate riddle. She was a mix of Drow and Elf, nothing strange in these times, but there was something else. Her true form was something equally evil as Lady Cala, something that distorted the flow of magic around her. She was like a magical vampire who absorbed the power around her. But most of her power came from a place he couldn't place beyond the fact that it was strange and terrifying. He wasn't an expert in forbidden knowledge and dark magic, but he didn't like her either, although the woman seemed less evil than her ward.

And then there was Rosie, perhaps the greatest mystery of all. A dna scan showed she was an ordinary human. Although it was difficult to determine her origins, she did not fit genetically into any of the factions of humanity, on other hand this species was so widespread in the galaxy that it was impossible to know them all, and her story sounded very credible. But she certainly wasn't who she said she was... He first became suspicious when he heard the kids talking about how she fought on Saltmarsh. Glowing hands and jumping on buildings were definitely not skills an intern should have. But he gained confidence during that training fight with Lady Cala. A being claiming to be an aristocrat should not be defeated in battle by any mortal, especially not one like Rosie. The girl was blazing with power like a flare in the dark, but at the same time she was bending the flow of magic around her. He couldn't explain it, but despite her nice and friendly nature, the white-haired girl aroused his concern much more than the supernatural monster and the sorceress corrupted by dark art.

But he knew more in another respect, too. His drones had a much greater range than others had thought... although that was no secret, all he had to do was read the instructions. Sometimes he had the impression that reading the documents attached to the products they bought was, for many inhabitants of the galaxy, an effort comparable to reading an ancient book written in a long-extinct ancient language... Thanks to the drones, he was able to observe Bina's wards. He started doing this after the events on

Saltmarsh, where he played fool and told the captain that he had no idea that the kids had gone into town alone. Fortunately, nothing really dangerous happened on Icarus. The princesses turned out to be really nice and understanding people. But here the situation got worse. First Eti set the bar on fire, and now Itel was planning something. First she disappeared into the forest, and now she ran into the ship and got into the hidden compartment where they kept... things they should never have used. He had to seek help... from other members of this expedition, none of whom, unfortunately, were completely trustworthy. He had to deal with what he had...

He felt lost. Once, not so long ago, he knew what was right and wrong, but now... Now he was helping the woman who hurt his friends... all of them. Which pushed his brother towards the worst evil. Why is he doing this? He wasn't entirely sure. It was probably also about fear. Even before he learned the truth about the dark sorceress, she terrified him. And now… He knew that she would be able to kill him without the slightest effort. Or she could wipe his memory and he would be that scared and lost creature who didn't even know his name. She could then shape him however she wanted, just as she had tried to do with Adora . She would force him to turn against his friends. He would give his life for his friends, but the thought of becoming someone's slave again terrified him. But it wasn't just about fear. He was taught obedience and always had problems making independent decisions. And now his brother told him to be silent, just as he had been when he left Etheria. He trusted Hordak , he was the most experienced of all the clones and Entrapta's beloved, but... He wasn't sure if he was wrong in this case, he wouldn't let this woman manipulate him again, after all, she knew him better than even the ruler of Dryl. Unfortunately, and worse, even auntie Casta and Glimmer’s dad, as he learned from listening to his young friends, had no objection to this evil woman's return to Etheria.

But the worst part was the remorse. He hid the truth from his new

friends even from Rosie who was always nice to him and Eti who was somehow involved with Catra. He didn't tell them that they would be traveling with the sorceress who had hurt their scout's sister so much. He was a fool who allowed the servant of darkness to return to Etheria so that she could continue to do evil. In his defense, she was really nice to Eti and Rosie, and even to him... It was all a lie though. He knew well how easily others could be deceived by lies and seemingly noble words. He knew it firsthand. He was, after all, a clone of Horde Prime .

He barely slept that night and barely ate dinner, listening to his young friends talk about Mikah, whom Itel, for completely incomprehensible reasons, mistook for an Azlanti. privateer, and mysterious Heart Gift that everyone felt sorry for, and then they went to Brightmoon . He missed this city very much, although not as much as he missed his friends. But he couldn't meet them because he wouldn't be able to hide the truth from them, and he wouldn't know what he would do if it was revealed. Wouldn't Shadow Weaver be willing to punish his new friends instead. He knew from Catra's stories that she could be cruel and ruthless. That's why he decided to explore the city with Emily.

He immediately noticed how much it had grown. They were now surrounded by a true Energy Shield, protecting the inhabitants from attacks by enemies that might come from outer space. He saw how diverse this city had become now. He saw here not only the former inhabitants of the Etherian Horde, but also people from other planets such as Icarus , and even his Brothers, although not many. He learned that most of them now live either in the former Fright Zone or in Plumeria. As he watched the joyful inhabitants of the capital, he felt a renewed sense of guilt, for he knew how unaware they were of the evil walking beside them, which he had helped bring here.

Suddenly he was surprised to see something he had never seen before on Etheria, the true temple. As far as he knew, there were no temples on Etheria so far, in fact he had never heard any of his friends ever mention gods or things like that. He wasn't sure what to think about religion. The Horde prime ordered him to be

worshiped almost as if he were a god himself and at the same time he ordered the destruction of the temples of the so-called false gods. But many of his Skittermanders were religious, and one was even a true priest of Desna. So everything was ambiguous and not obvious to him. Emily chirped at him curiously, she was definitely more fond of priests and temples, especially a one android who was a Triune priest… He nodded and said.

„Yes you are right. We'll look here. Maybe we'll find something that will help us make the right decision.”

The interior was bright and transparent. He had seen many stained glass windows here, but in a different style than the ones he usually saw on Etheri. First of all, they had eyes, something that was avoided on this planet when images of intelligent beings were created. The characters they depicted were familiar to him, although here they were all gnomes. There was the good and merciful Serenae, the brave Caiden , the terrible Asmodeus... He approached the image of the warrior but also noble Iomadae. He always liked this goddess because she reminded him a lot of She-Ra, although it wasn't as noticeable here because... well, she was a gnome.

„Oh, hello, I'm glad you visited the temple of All Gods... This is Iomdi ... let me tell you about her.” said a tall, gnome woman with golden hair and eagle wings. He didn't see her at first when he entered. He smiled and said.

„I know who she is. I even went to the Ascension Day celebration once. This was on Vesk III. There they call it Iomadae. She is liked by the nicer Vesks who do not want to listen to the conquest-hungry Damoritosh.”

„Oh, Each God may be known by a thousand names and in a thousand forms, but there is only one soul. I haven't heard of Vesk III, although I don't know most of the planets conquered by your... By Horde Prime.„ She smiled at him, but he shook his head in response.

„It's outside the empire, in Veskarium . He never got there, I'm not even sure he could handle it. The Vesks are warlike and know magic”.

The winged woman's eyes lit up with unconcealed joy.

„ It's wonderful that belief in gods has survived in the galaxy! We, the people of Eridani, are often treated as weird because of our religiosity... Here on Etheria, everyone is especially suspicious because their first contact with faith was through Horde Prime. Not many people visit this place, but I am not discouraged and I work patiently. HordeH Oh, I forgot. My name is Brine.” she offered him her hand, which he shook with a friendly smile. Then they both looked at Emily, who was looking around the temple indignantly.

„What is this Bot looking for?” Brine asked with surprise.

„I think he's looking for Triune's portrait. He likes them very much.” he explained to the priestess, who looked at him with surprise.

„I've never heard of such a god, at least by that name.”

He shook his head and began to explain.

„These are very young gods... They patronize wise machines, like Emily, and journeys through the Drift.”

The priestess began to look at him curiously.

„Are there any other gods there that I didn't know about?” Brine asked with joy in her voice.

He thought for a moment and said.

„ I don't know much about this type of thing. There is Damoritosh, but I don't like him very much. He is the god of war and conquest, he reminds me too much of His... Horde Prime. The Vesks respect him. They are such warlike and honorable lizards. Their relatives live here on Etheri, but they are completely different from those in Veskarium. And then there is Hylax , goddess of the collective mind, friendship and community. He is the patron of Shirens, species of friendly Insectoids , quite nice, most of them... I think she would be liked here on Etheria. There are a few other gods, but I don't know much about them, I've never been interested in religion.”

Though his information was sparse, Priestess Brine noted everything.

„Thank you very much. Thanks to you, I learned a lot about the universe and its secrets.” she hugged him tightly and friendly, making him blush.

„Oh, hello Brondak, it's nice to have you here. I'll just pray and we can go for coffee or whatever they drink! here” Ireanis called from the entrance. Brine immediately ran to greet her. He felt a slight twinge of jealousy, but also anxiety. He was afraid of Shadow Weaver, but this Elf aroused his dislike. She seemed to know the true identity of the dark sorceress, but she didn't seem to care about it, even though that terrible person was threat to her friends! Had the alcohol completely eaten her brain? He had absolutely no idea, although his brother had a very deep disgust for all drugs. He waited a few minutes while the sorceress prayed before the images of Cayden and Serenae, and then he followed her outside.

„Ah, isn't it beautiful here, Bondak?” Ireanis asked him, looking around with sincere delight.

„My name is Wrongdak, we have been traveling together for a month, you should know my name by now.” he said with undisguised resentment in his voice.

„You know, I was a bit drunk most of the trip, so I didn't remember everything.” she explained to him with a goofy smile on her face.

“Is that why it doesn't bother you that you work with someone like her?” he asked sharply. The silver-haired sorceress looked down as if she was considering something and finally spoke in a surprisingly serious tone.

„I'm not someone who would have the right to judge her. Out of fear, I threw my disciples into the black flame of Ashaq The Annihilator”

„What? What are you talking about, sorceress?„ he asked with surprise.

She turned to him.

„Where I lived, there was a vile dragon called Ashaq the Annihilator. It was a terrible undead monster, a vampire that left only death and ashes in its wake. Natambu, the wonderful and ancient city where I once lived, decided to organize an expedition to defeat this evil once and for all. I commanded a unit of war mages who were supposed to bring down this monster with their power. Most of my comrades in arms were my former students. Together we were sure of victory, in fact we celebrated it. But when we faced this terrible creature... It was able to kill dozens of soldiers with one breath, and then they fought against us as undead. He regenerated all the wounds we inflicted on him as he absorbed the lives of the combatants. However, we were so close to victory, but it was uncertain, so Ashaq contacted me and offered to let me go if I betrayed my comrades. So I did. I was so afraid of dying, of becoming undead. I should have been strong, I should have been brave, but I turned out to be just a coward. I survived, but I abandoned my companions. In Nantambu I told a probably sounding fairy tale. Some believed me and took pity on me, but others saw through the lie and condemned me, and I started drinking.”

After hearing this story, he remained silent, because what could be said... He simply hugged the woman and let her cry on his shoulder. After a while, however, a voice came from the sky.

„I'm sorry to interrupt such an intimate moment, but I have to inform Mrs. Ireanis that Itel has just found her way to the hidden compartment, and Eti is nowhere to be found.”

The sorceress broke free from his grip and ran towards the ship, shouting loudly, "Fuck, fuck, fuck."

He exchanged a look with Emily, shrugged, and ran after the silver-haired woman.

She rested her head on Miss Daisy's shoulder and stared at the sky full of stars. Miss Daisy, Light Spinner ... Shadow Weaver... She loved her under all her names, no matter what past they hid. She had been sneezing from the very beginning, ever since that ball at Archduke Adamson's court. Then there was that trip to Kranor Rill, where they both almost died, where she became sure of her feelings. She thought that this trip would separate them, but it turned out that they would meet on this planet and be together, at least for a short while...

First, they walked through a city full of beings so unaware of the darkness she had faced all her life... No, they were not unaware of the darkness, they had received their share of evil too... they just overcame it. Yes, these Etherians were so strong and brave, but they had not lost that something that made them so open and joyful. Many of her brothers and sisters could learn from them.

She wanted to buy a bottle of wine and a basket of fruit, but her lover said she had given up drinking, so they took a carafe of lemonade, quite sour. She was proud of the sorceress, because already during that ball she noticed that the woman had a drinking problem, and her stay in Grayskull Castle confirmed her

in this belief. Fighting addiction was difficult, it required strength that even other hell knights often lacked.

While walking around the city, they didn't talk much, just their closeness was enough. They held hands, although they tried not to let anyone notice that the sorceress was wearing a holographic mask, even people as open-minded as the inhabitants of this planet could react to the sight of Miss Daisy's true face. Even she didn't want to think too much about the reason for what happened to her beloved. She just wanted to enjoy her presence... At first she felt awkward, feeling the stares of passers-by, but when they smiled at her, she smiled back at them.

He was dismayed at the sight of the sorceress's young charges, and when she saw that he was meditating with this silver-haired elf, she felt an involuntary twinge of jealousy, but now they were together, lying on the green grass, not caring what fate would bring. She knew that her beloved was hiding some dark secret, but the same could be said about her. However, as they lay there together, she suddenly heard a loud, slightly metallic voice speaking.

„Sorry to interrupt your happy moments, but I would suggest that Miss Daisy return to the ship as soon as possible if you want to prevent an incident involving the use of nuclear weapons.”

We feel the evil coming...

We feel the evil coming…

Coming back from the Kingdom of Snow wasn't easy... Not that anyone would dare to stop them, not even that son of bitch Chancellor would try something so stupid. No, this was about something completely different. When she set out on this journey, her only concern was her origins, that she had somehow ended up here from outside of Etheria. But it didn't really matter... At least that's what she tried to tell herself. But now... First Lonnie's attack using a weapon of unknown origin, then the discovery of another dark chapter in Etheria's history, then Adora bringing news about Queen Angela, and now this... She couldn't believe how quickly the joy of victory could turn into the bitterness of defeat. Could they have prevented this? She doubted this. "It all started long before this that adventure. The Shadow Weaver's sisters and the Chancellor have been developing this plot for long time... They have been weaving their dark web for months. How typical of this lousy family. ' She thought bitterly. She wasn't sure if Lonnie had any part in this plot. Back when they were cadets, Lonnie was always the one who accused her of foul play and cunning. She doubted that her former friend had changed so much. But did it even matter? She looked at Frosta, who was sitting fastened in a chair and staring blankly into space. Earlier, she cried for a while and asked if she had really failed her kingdom, now she was just silent, deep in despair, which was even worse. They tried to comfort her down, but they couldn't, because what they could do was that her own government didn't want her. She had no idea what the common people of the kingdom thought of their ruler. She had never visited this kingdom, it was stupid to admit it, but she didn't like the cold, especially the fact that her tail was freezing. "This is one of our many negligences. In their complacency, they took it for granted that everyone wanted them to rule or were happy with the situation on Etheria. When I come back and the wedding is over, we will have to take a trip around Etheria and find out what the

mood is on the planet. Maybe if we had done this earlier, Frosta would still be the ruler of her kingdom now.” She clenched her fists in anger, because it was Lonnie's fault and what she preached. It was because of her that Frosta lost her home overnight. The former cadet's anger towards her has unleashed something she can no longer control, which could lead to the disintegration of all of Etheri. *Isn't shea bit like me? I almost destroyed an entire planet because my anger blinded me so much. I'm no better than you, Lonnie, but you're no better than me either.*

When they landed near Netossa's court, the ruler of Armoria took Frosta with her. Before her friend left the deck, she asked her.

„Are you sure you don't want to come with us to Brightmoon? Glimmer will be happy to have you visit. Besides, victory day is coming soon and we'll need you at our wedding.”

Tears appeared in the Ice Princess's eyes again.

„NO! Glimmer can't see me now! I failed her! She lost entire kingdom because of me! I'm just a stupid little Frosta that even my own people don't want.”

Adora stood next to her and smiled as she said.

„Now rest with Shogi , because it was a difficult trip, but you must come to our wedding, because who better to take care of the guests' safety. You will do it best, because you are the bravest of all princesses.

She nodded half-heartedly and petted Shogi , who was mewling pitifully.

„Yes, if I'm needed, I'll come, but I don't know if it's a good idea.”

They left her with Spinnerela, who come with Quickling and Greypaw to greet the Ice Princess. Netossa also stayed there, reluctantly handing over the family treasure to Entrapta to use with the express order that she should make no improvements,

modifications or corrections. The inventor was to take them to Brightmoon, and then return to the united kingdom, from where she would drive away in her automated Skimmer, which in turn would give them back on their Wedding Day... Or not. It would be good for the former ruler of Dryl to have her own means of transport to visit them and not be tied to her castle. With similar thoughts, she approached Entrapta sitting in the cockpit and spoke in a serious voice.

„Listen. When I get back to the castle, I'll talk to Glimmer and arrange for... all three of you to come to the wedding."

Entrapta looked at her in surprise.

„But we have already received an invitation to the wedding."

She was about to explain to her friend that the invitation almost certainly didn't mention Hordak, but she thought better of it and just hugged her tightly.

They reached Brightmoon at night, so Entrapta would probably have to stay here until morning to sleep. The three of them went out to the castle landing field, where there was surprising confusion. They waited for a few moments for Glimmer, to see her running towards them with Bow. She frowned, feeling a twinge of anxiety. Sparkle didn't like running around the palace when she didn't have to, and she absolutely always teleported to them when they arrived in Brightmoon after a long absence and gave them a hug. You knew from her friends' stories that, apart from her time in space before the Heart's destruction, the last time something like this had happened was when she escaped from Shadow Weaver's captivity when she was somehow cursed. Adora thought the same thing as she became very tense.

„Catra! Adora! It's great that you're here! And you too, Entrapta! You will definitely come in handy here! Come with me!„ Glimmer spoke so fast that her words blurred into one string and she

turned on her heel and was already running back, but she stopped her while talking.

„Sparkle, we also have important news... I think you should listen it.” she said carefully. Entrapta looked between her and the queen.

„Whatever you have to tell me, it can wait. There's someone here you should meet.” Glimmer gestured excitedly. She sighed. Perhaps an ambassador must have arrived from one of the previously unknown planets conquered by Prime. There were so many of them that no one, except perhaps the mad Tyrant, could count them. Melog's tail wagged slightly greenish yellow due to anxiety and confusion. She took a deep breath and said.

„Whoever this person is, they can wait.” she started, but Adora interrupted.

„Glimmer, your Mom... She's alive... but.” her fiancée lowered her eyes. The Queen stared at them for a long moment, as if she didn't understand what they were saying, and then she blinked, her eyes widening in a mixture of disbelief and delight. Only now did she notice that Glimmer had a black eye and a bite mark on her hand. Who was she training with?

„Is she here with you?” the ruler of Brightmoon asked hopefully, and Melog sniffed the bite and suddenly felt an urgency from him, as if he really wanted to go to where Sparkle had come from.

„No, she's not here. Oh Glimmer, I'm so sorry.” Adora said and looked down. Glimmer closed her eyes and shook her head.

„Then we can wait a little longer. She is here. Her name is Eti and… You have to see her.” there was so much excitement and concern in Glimmer's voice that she was scared herself, and Melog nudged her urgently with his head.

„Is Eti here? That's great! I was telling Catra about her and her friends. We met on Icarus . She knows your mom… or person who she has become... „ Adora hesitated, Glimmer looked at her carefully, and Bow asked.

„But have you seen her face?”

Adora nodded cautiously.

„Well, yes... although not entirely, because she was wearing a mask on her face... I guess she had a terrible accident, she probably lost her hand during it, and... this hand is an artifact of the First Ones „ said the heroine of the universe and Entrapta shook his hair, and fires lit up in her eyes or pure joy.

„Artifact of the First Ones! Lead the way!” exclaimed the Inventor and almost started running on her own. Her anxiety grew as she remembered a dream...

„You didn't say she didn't have a hand.” she whispered, and Melog glowed blue.

„So you didn't see her face...„ Glimmer said quietly, and she felt a shiver run down her spine.

„Her face.” she understood why Melog was rushing her so much and she started running on all fours.

„This is definitely a bad idea.” Rosie tried to say, but she still had no gloves, and Eti was kidnapped by the queen, so there was no one to translate what she said.

„Stop waving those paws, just be useful for something and hold the other side.” Itel said with a furious expression and pointed to a large metal object that they had pulled out of a hidden compartment on the ship.

Escaping from the castle wasn't as difficult as they expected, although at first itel wanted to look for the cat girl, but Alatar talked her out of it, saying that they wouldn't be able to fight the entire guard, although Lilka was convinced that they could handle it without any problems.

“I'm an orc, I can deal with even a hundred of these guards myself, and you take fifty each and we'll manage somehow.” the red-haired girl explained. They didn't argue with her.

To be honest, she wasn't sure whether the technomancer's words had convinced the elf or whether she had simply come up with a new, better plan. which she began to put into practice as soon as they reached the ship. She led them to a hidden part of the ship where they hid many things that made her worry. After a while, she chose an oblong and very heavy object with a nuclear threat symbol on the lid. The four of them managed to carry him aboard and then rested, but only for a moment as Itel urged them on. Toshi flew around scared, looking for his lady and when he didn't find her, he started rubbing against the others for comfort, but no one had the time or inclination to take care of the blue fox right now, so he lay down on the couch, squealing sadly. She tried to reason with itel but due to her rush, she didn't put on her gloves. Fortunately, Mr. Ilemshaw came to her with rescue.

„Since I know most of the basic languages, including Absalomian Sign Language, let me help with translation. Miss Rosie says your plan isn't very good, and she's right, no matter what it is, because using nuclear weapons is never a good idea.” Said the representative of a race unknown to her in a metallic voice. Itel clenched her jaw angrily.

„ It's her fault! Eti got trapped because of that deaf idiot and now we have to save her!” she summoned the moonblade and threatened the camera

„Personally, I think that the current situation you are in is the result of you deciding to do a very unwise thing, but you are unlikely to remedy it by doing another unwise thing out of emotion... And what are you actually going to do? “asked Mr. Ilemshaw. Itel hesitated, as if she was just now trying to put her plan into words.

„I'm going to threaten to detonate this warhead if they don't release Eti.” she said with weakening conviction. When she

finished, the entire room went dark and Miss Daisy appeared in the ship, followed by Ireanis and Wrongdak .

„This is the most ridiculous rescue plan I have ever heard of, believe it or not, in my long life.”

These were happy moments spent together with the woman she loved. But all happy things come to an end. At first she didn't understand what the fish-like alien was talking about, the idea of nuclear weapons wasn’t something she had heard about before coming to the Pact Worlds, but when she saw the horror in Asindesa's eyes, she finally understood what it meant and jumped to her feet.

„I'm sorry, dearest, but I have to go... As you heard, something unforeseeable happened... „ she started hastily explaining to the Hell Knight who was looking at her not cleary understanding what was happening.

„Nuclear weapons? Where ... why?” She asked slowly regaining her composure. She placed her hand on the blade of the sword, and the tenacity she remembered from Krannor Rill flashed in her eyes .

„I haven't the slightest idea, but I have to act anyway.” she said, and Asindesa kissed her on the lips.

„ Look after yourself,. Meanwhile, I'll go to the castle and see what I can do.” said the Hell Knight with concern in her voice. She smiled at her and stepped into the cold darkness.

She arrived on the ship just in time to learn about Itel's plan and comment on it. The elf summoned her blade and looked at her hostilely.

"It's none of your business," she pointed her weapon at her. She sighed and said.

„As far as I know, a nuclear explosion is the business of anyone who may be caught in its radius, but besides that, your captain entrusted me with the task of taking care of you, which, I must admit with a heavy heart, I was unable to cope with. Now, please, take a deep breath and tell me what happened.” she tried to talk to them, just like she talked to Adora. It must have worked, because although Itel continued to grit her teeth angrily, Alatar began to tell her about the recent events. When he finished, she felt relieved. It could have been a lot worse. Actually, nothing bad happened at all, maybe it would even be better if they met Catra under controlled conditions. *Even when I, the woman who harmed this planet so much, was imprisoned, they provided me conditions that most of the inhabitants of the galaxy could dream of* she thought, although at the same time she knew that she couldn't tell her wards anything, because then she would have to explain how she knew how to treat prisoners on Etheria. Fortunately, Wrongdak came with the help. The clone smiled, since he learned the truth about her he did it less often, and said in a warm tone.

„I know Glimmer. She is brave and strong, but she won't do anything to Eti. I can vouch for that.”

The kids looked at each other confused, but relaxed, even Itel. She smiled at them and said.

„Mr. Wrongdak speaks wisely. Hasty actions can only lead to an escalation of the situation, which will only worsen the situation in which Eti finds herself. It would be best if we wait until the morning, rest, cool down. Mr. Wrongdak will take you to the palace, given his relationship with the ruler, it shouldn't be difficult for him to obtain an audience with her, and you will politely apologize to the queen and ask for Eti's release.” she said, and the clone looked at her suspiciously. Well, she was risking a lot, because the clone could have handed her over to the authorities with impunity, but it was still the safest option. The situation seemed to be calming down when suddenly she heard Mr. Ilemshaw's voice, in which, despite the metallic sound, she heard pure fear.

„I detected a message coming from orbit. A ship has arrived in Etheria , with Lord Admiral Antares on board”

She felt a chill run down her spine. Everyone except Wrongdak, Emily, and Rosie looked extremely terrified.

„Okay, we have to improvise. – she said and rubbed her face with her hand. "Focus, don't let yourself get distracted... How I hate improvising"

Eti took a few deep breaths and looked around. She had a strange feeling that she was in a bedroom. There was a four-poster bed, lots of pillows, shooting targets, more pillows, a waterfall, and some more pillows. If she weren't so angry and... terrified, she would have found this place unsettling... and her eyes hurt from how colorful it was. She had spent the last half hour screaming, threatening, and punching the magical barrier to no avail until her hair stood straight from the feedback. She didn't want to stay here, she hated being locked in, with no way out. When she didn't have a name yet, only a number, she was imprisoned, watched without a moment of privacy, without the right to decide about herself in any matters. She would never allow to be treated like that again, even if she had to bite her veins. The hag and her guy left her with one of the clones, Brother of Wrongdak, who was dressed in a guard's outfit and had long hair hanging down his back. He didn't take his eyes off her and tried to look as serious as possible. She rested her head on her shoulder and thought. She didn't met any other clones apart from Wrongdak, and she wasn't sure how similar he was to the other clones, but they were all identical, at least at first, and they had only gained freedom a few years ago... Before that, they were servants of a mad tyrant who demanded absolute obedience from them. She doubted they had changed much in that time. She looked at the top, there was a vent. She would smile very broadly if she could. She put her arms around her and said.

„I demand to speak to my lawyer.”

The clone looked at her in surprise.

„ Are you demanding? To speak? With a lawyer?” He spoke each word separately, clearly confused

„Is Etheria a place where the basic rights of all sentient beings are respected?” She asked in a cold voice.

„Of course.” He assured her.

„So I'm asking you to bring me my lawyer, without it I can't defend myself. It was enough of a violation of my rights that your Queen neither brought any charges against me nor informed me of my rights. Of course, such practices are not common in the Galaxy. In places where authoritarian, or even worse, totalitarian, governments prevail, as in Prime's Empire, they are of course not respected, and the fate of each citizen depends only on the will of the ruling tyrant. I assume that Etheria is one of such places, and you are just a helpless cog in a system of oppression that obediently follows every order yo6receives. „ she said in a calm, dispassionate voice, keeping her eyes on the clone. She knew she had hit a nerve. For this purpose, she used the knowledge about the minds of thinking beings, which Jantar drilled into her soul, so that she could better fulfill her destiny. She hated it, even though she was really good at it, but she had no intention of staying here any longer. The clone finally asked after much thought.

„But where can I get a lawyer at this time, it's the middle of the night and I don't even know where to look for him.

She sighed with false irritation and said as if she was explaining to an ignorant but quite nice young person.

„To be honest, it's none of my business, but I don't want to stay here any longer, but from what I know, Swiftwind , your She-Ra's steed, has the qualifications of a lawyer, he told me about it yesterday. You'll definitely find it around town. He lives in a big tent.”

He nodded and ran out of the room. She did better than I expected. With any luck, the guy will be looking for a tent for perhaps an hour. She's gained a lot of time. Bina would be proud of her. First she decided to contact her friends. To her surprise, no one was blocking communication here.

„Hi how are you?" she asked.

„Eti. It's so good to hear from you. Are you OK?„ the elf asked with a breaking voice.

„The Queen took me to her bedroom and the King sprayed me with something damn sticky. But apart from that, everything's fine."

„I'LL FUCKING MURDER THEM ALL!" Itel roared…

She think she chose the wrong words...

For a moment, hard to understand words and screams could be heard on the other side, and then Alatar spoke.

„ Think sometimes about what you are saying, Eti. Itel almost attacked Miss Daisy with the Knife... Actually, not almost.

„Okay, sorry...„ she said quite embarrassed "The Hag wasn't very good at spells, almost as bad as Ireanis, I think it was because of how the sparkling paw hit her. She's great, isn't she? And then Strzała, her guy, hit me with an arrow that covered me with something sticky... That's it. – She explained, hoping that she managed to calm her friend down.

„It's not that important, Eti." there was something in Alatar's voice that made her ears perk up. "We have a bigger problem. The Lord Admiral is here."

In fact, it was not true that she did not feel fear. She simply felt it less strongly and towards other things. And now she felt terrified like never before in her short life.

... And shadows all around

She didn't fully understand why Catra ran so fast to see the other girl, but she should probably be happy about it, because she wanted from her to do that, but she didn't have to run so fast right away. She had to keep up, but she felt like she was going to spit her lungs out. Did running cause her so much difficulty, or was it she who lost her fitness? Maybe she should walk around the castle more instead of teleporting all the time? On other hand the castle was so damn big and teleporting was so cool!

Entrapta ran right next to Catra, it always amazed her how a woman who spent so much time in the lab could be so incredibly physically fit. She guess it was because she had to carry all these tools and equipment everywhere she went as well avoid the explosions she caused on a regular basis s. Adora had always been as agile as Catra, but now even she couldn't keep up with her. Maybe if she transformed into She-Ra, but she guessed there was no need for that. When she started panting, Bow took her arm.

„Thanks Honey." she panted and now she had a little less trouble keeping up with the others, a little less.

Despite the effort, Adora's words kept echoing in the back of her mind. "Your mom… she is alive." For now, their full meaning did not reach her. She knew she should cry from happiness at this news, but... she was already used to the thought that her mother was dead, that she was gone and she would never see her again, unless those who said there was something after death were right. But if she is alive... Hordak had told Catra that she wasn't dead, that she was trapped in a space beyond time, but she wasn't sure how much she could trust the former leader of the Etherian Horde. Besides, it would require reopening the portal, the

consequences of which could be so dire that even Entrapta didn't want to talk about this. But now it turned out that she was alive, just like that, and that she even knew the other Catra... But why did Adora look so distraught when she mentioned her mom? She'll find out all about it soon, just let Catra meet the other one.

The five of them ran into the bedroom together. The five of them ran into the bedroom together... Only to find the circle was gone and see the tail disappear into the vent. She probably should have done a full bonding circle, but her defense was that she was in real hurry. Catra lunged forward with Melog radiating blue and green, but they both bounced off the magical barrier.

„Take it off!" demanded the Grand Marshal. She made a few quick gestures and the circle disappeared, but that was enough for the prisoner to escape. Catra jumped in immediately after her, using her cat-like flexibility, and Entrapta ran after her. The others wouldn't be able to squeeze through the opening. Normally she would have teleported to the other side, but she felt that her power was still not working, probably because of the blow the white-haired girl had dealt. So they stopped for a moment, using this time to catch their breath and think about what they should do next, but then Onyx Sky burst into the bedroom.

„Oh, its good that you are on your feet, Queen... An urgent message arrived." They said with excitement.

That's three in an hour.

„I guess it'll have to wait a bit, though, because we're in the middle of something of a chase." she said as soon as she regained her breath, but then she realized that she saw pure terror in Onyx Sky's eyes. If something inspired fear even in someone raised in Prime's Empire, it must have been truly terrible.

„Lord Admiral Antares, High Commander of the Research and Exploration Fleet, requests a meeting with Queen Glimmer, Adora She-Ra, and Grand Marshal Catra." They explained. She let out a

few particularly lousy curse words that made Adora and Bow blush.

„What Fleet? What Admiral? What are they talking about?” Adora asked impatiently, because she was about to run after Catra. She buried her face in her hands, it was just starting to be too much. Everything fell on her at once. He has to figure it all out somehow before it all collapses.

„A lot of things happened while you were gone. Adora, follow Catra, Bow and I will prepare for the official audience.”

She ran, although she didn't fully understand why. But she remembered that dream and that girl... She had to see her, had to make sure it was that girl. The girl with twin-colored eyes... She didn't believe in dreams until now. She was taught that they were just the trash of the mind. Even when she had dreams, after she believed she had sentenced Entrapta to death, she knew it was the result of her remorse, her self-loathing. It was one of the few good things she got from the Fright Zone and from Shadow Weaver's teaching. She was a rationalist who believed what she saw. This time, however, it was different... In this dream, she learned about things she had no idea about, and now there was someone who looked similar to the person from her dream. Melog remembered her and confirmed that she smelled similar to her, and to his lady.

However, as soon as she ran into Glimmer's bedroom, she saw that she was running away. It took a few precious moments to break the spell, so she lost a few precious seconds before she could continue her pursuit. Then she ran into the vent. Immediately after they emerged from the tunnel, a mad chase began through the dim corridors of Brightmoon . They used their sense of smell to track her down. She had the impression that the other woman was aware of the layout of the palace and was finding her way around the palace effortlessly, as if she knew right way... Was someone helping her, or maybe she had simply

obtained a map of the castle somehow. Despite her efforts, she was unable to raise security to the level she wanted. They could have gotten them from someone for pretty eyes. Or maybe they had hacked into the computer system, according to several Icarus residents their computer security system was worse than none. Just as she thought about it, all the lights in the castle went out and darkness reigned. She could see with her cat-like eyesight, just like Melog, and Entrapta's mask had night vision, though she wasn't sure if the inventor could see in the dark herself. Most of the remaining inhabitants of the castle, however, were blind in this darkness. So someone had broken into the castle's system after all... yes, that was a good explanation...

They ran into a large gallery with wide windows on the sides. They saw her. She was just as she remembered her from her dream. A long coat, heavy boots and that metal hand. Entrapta squealed with delight when she saw her, but she didn't listen to her. All she saw was a runaway woman. She flexed her leg muscles and jumped towards the other girl. She was right next to her. She grabbed her left hand, the one with the glove, but the other one kicked her in the chest with all her strength, knocking her back. She almost fell over, but Entrapta caught her with her hair.

„Is it amazing? This hand is so similar to a sword, but... „ She did not listen to the inventor's further explanation. That girl ran away and kept getting further away, and only the glove was left in her hand. She growled and started running again. The girl's outfit seemed to slow her down, or it was the adrenaline that gave her strength. Soon she started to catch up. But then the darkness around her began to deepen, as if the shadows around her grew and thickened. She felt a cold, all too familiar. She had experienced it many times, always when she had enraged Shadow Weaver with something. *Can not be. She's gone. She die. It's just a hallucination from the effort* she thought, but she felt from Melog that it wasn't just an illusion... The shadows slowed her down a bit and the distance between them increased again. All she had left was a leather glove.

„She's behind me. Right behind me.” Eti exclaimed, not slowing down even for a moment.

„Turn left. There you will reach a large garden, you can easily hide there. Focus, don't get distracted.” Miss Daisy replied. She watched her with her shadows and guided the way while Alatar hacked the system.

„How do you know the layout of this castle so well?” she asked, feeling a strange twinge of anxiety.

„It's not important now. Don't slow down, I'll be able to transport you soon.” The dark sorceress replied sharply But she wasn't going to listen to her, not yet. She had to do something she had been waiting for for over two thousand two hundred days.

„Alatar, hack into the main communications system.”

She ran outside… It took her a few moments to realize she was in Shadow Weaver's former garden. Now it was kept wild, it was a great place for the other girl to hide… She looked around and called out.

„You don't have to run away... I won't do anything to you...”

„Your friend, the Hag and her Arrow-boy wanted to imprison me!” There was a voice coming from the loudspeakers installed on the seas to make announcements and transmit orders... They hacked that too .

„It was... A misunderstanding.„ She exclaimed, looking around. She hoped that that girl, that Eti, heard her correctly.

„ Misunderstanding... I know such misunderstandings. It doesn't matter anyway... You know, I've known about you for as long as I can remember. Since always” the other girl's voice was so dull and

emotionless. She tried to sniff out her, but this garden was so full of different smells that she couldn't find the other one... *Even now, after all those years you're throwing obstacles in my way.* she thought angrily, trying to pick up a scent in Shadow Weaver's garden. Melog walked with his nose to the ground, although he didn't have to rely solely on his sense of smell to find it. He had his own, unique senses. Entrapta was tearing through the bushes, barely visible. She could be almost invisible when she wanted to. That's probably how she coped in the Fright Zone and Beast Island.

„Do you know the Tale of the Scorpion and the Frog?" a question came from the speakers.

„The one where the scorpion stings the frog at the end? I heard it many times as a child." she said, raising her voice a little so that the other could hear her. Shadow Weaver loved telling her this story with a clear hint that she was the Scorpion and Adora was the Frog. She later discovered that Scorpia knew another version of it, where Scorpion and the Frog had lots of adventures and eventually got married. Years later, she decided that she liked the latter much more."

„You know, I used to be afraid of our meeting, of what I would do when I saw you... I was afraid that I would do something very bad, but it turned out to be different. I only feel peace. All-encompassing bliss. Catharsis. Because I finally understood something... „ She heard a short, broken laugh, dry as the crunching of gravel under shoes. "We will not deny our nature, we will not escape from our destiny. It's like a curse that hangs over us. But it's not about running away from our destiny, but really understanding what it is. You came to a place forgotten by devils and demons, the existence of which no one knew., and you still followed the path that was chosen for you, even though you received no preparation, while I, an absolutely perfect, awesome and unique being, I am... who I am...„ the last words are no more were coming from the speakers so she could tell where the girl was, so she ran towards it and Entrapta and Melog followed her.

She was waiting for her, standing on the battlements. She had it down and her mask off. Her dark red hair flowed loosely against the starry night sky.

„So we finally meet.„ the other girl said, then turned to her and looked at her with golden cat eyes full of blue dots that seemed to glow like icy flames. “Hey Sis.”

At that moment she froze. She had no idea what she should do. Her whole life, all her adventures and journeys, hardships and suffering, did not prepare her for what happened here. She could only stand there and stare blankly, unable to even move or form a single thought.

Then, slowly and timidly, joy began to flow into her heart. Something completely unbelievable happened. She found her sister, or rather she found her, but it didn't matter. She had a sister, a family. She wanted to scream and laugh. Tears of joy flowed down her cheeks. She took a step forward, but then the other woman held out her hands in warning. The right one was made of metal, not like the prosthetics of Tallstar and other inhabitants of Ikarus, but rather as if cast from one piece of a substance resembling the one from which Adora's sword was made. It was undoubtedly an artifact of the First Ones. At the sight of him, Entrapta squealed with joy and stretched her hair towards her hand to touch it, at least with the tips. However, what caught her attention was the other hand. At first glance, it was normal, but someone had de-clawed it in a brutal and cruel way, so much so that the phalanges were almost cut off.

„Who did it to you?” she asked with a mixture of horror and anger. Her sister looked at her hand in confusion and said.

„It was a one evil woman, but it doesn't matter anymore... Listen.” she looked into her eyes. “Don't trust him. Everything he tells you is lies, everything.” and she jumped off the wall. Filled with terror, she rushed to catch it, but when she touched it, she was transformed into a shadow with a glowing three-lobed eye. To her right, along the vertical wall, her sister was running.

”Amazing! Real shoes which are creating their own gravity field. I have to make one like this! You know how much easier they would make my job! „ the inventor scramed, but she didn't listen to her, she just watched the running girl who suddenly jumped from the wall onto the balcony, to meet a figure wrapped in shadows and disappeared.

Can not be. You're dead.

It took her far too long to find Catra. She should know the layout of the castle better. She felt as if she had failed once again. First Glimmer's mother, then Frosta and now this strange girl... She needs to try harder if she cares about her friends. The confusion caused by the lights suddenly going out didn't help. She wasn't sure what had happened, but he guessed it had to do with the other girl. Fortunately, She- Ra's light was able to illuminate even the deepest darkness.

She found her love in Shadow Weaver's former garden. She didn't like coming here, she always felt uncomfortable here, as if this vile woman had polluted this place with her presence. Catra had no problem visiting this place, but she had never seen the Dark Sorceress working here always with her pruning shears in her hands. She always liked to trim everyone to shape them the way she wanted, she thought bitterly.

Catra sat crouched on the bench, Melog had his head in her lap, radiating sadness and fear. and Entrapta wrapped her hair around her like a blanket. Frightened, she ran to her fiancée and hugged her tightly.

„Are you okay? Hasn't she done anything to you?”

Catra looked at her with tearful eyes. They were red and their pupils were dilated, but she smiled and spoke in an almost joyful voice

„She didn't do anything to me... She's my sister. I have a sister Adora! Sister! But...„ here the cat girl's voice broke. "But there were shadows here. Her shadows. I think I even saw her. She lives Adora. She's alive and She has my sister...„ Now Catra started crying, and she felt her blood freeze in her veins. She remembered that shadow on Clytemnestra... At the time she had thought it was just a stress-induced illusion, but since even Catra, who could always see through any lie, had seen it too... She would deal with it later.

„I believe you, but now you have to come with me. Glimmer needs us... „ she said and Catra nodded and they went together to meet the Lord Admiral.

She hid one of her shadows in the throne room. She had already learned the art of spying on others in Mystacor, and had become very skilled at it in the Fright Zone. She needed this to track her rivals and obtain necessary information about them. Towards the end she didn't do it often anymore, she was running out of both strength and Rivals. But now these skills have proven useful again. Still, she had to be extremely careful.

Glimmer sat on a throne with a crown on her head. No trace remained of the fight with Eti. She wasn't sure if she hid it with makeup or used healing magic. Catra and Adora stood on her sides. The blonde haired woman was in She-Ra form. Catra wore a beautiful red and gold uniform, probably designed especially for her. The shock she had recently suffered was visible on her face, but she tried to stay tough, as always. Only her strange shape-shifting cat was shimmering in different colors, reflecting the mood of his lady. Bow stood slightly back in full gear so that at the slightest threat he could quickly draw his bow and fire. Entrapta was fidgeting nervously and writing something down on the datapad, not fully realizing the importance of the upcoming events The same could not be said for Prime Minister Shou, who was nervously clutching her robes. She didn't know her well, they only talked once after she came here from the Fright Zone. Her

species was known throughout the galaxy as the Brenneri, and they were renowned as empathetic diplomats. This explained perfectly why she felt so bad around her. Several other less important courtiers stood looking around nervously, fearing what was to come. Guards stood at full combat readiness, ready to give their lives for their queen, although if anything could threaten these four, all their courage and bravery would be in vain.

There was a deafening silence, even here, through the shadows, she could hear the sound of breathing, and she felt that if she concentrated a little more, she could feel the nervous beating of hearts. And then she heard Him. First there were footsteps, strong, soldierly. It was a firm march, but not hasty, befitting someone who never had to run anywhere to be on time because he was always the one for whom other where waiting. The footsteps in complete silence sounded like thunder, but were soon joined by another sound. An irritating and unpleasant melody that Bina and Eti often whistled. This time, the acoustics of the Throne Room made it almost painful. Catra and her pet flattened their ears and Adora gave her girlfriend a questioning look, but she only responded by shaking her head slightly.

And then he came in. He was dressed in a gold and scarlet uniform made of the finest fabrics, which was probably durable enough to be used as armor. Together with the jewels decorating it, it must have been worth a small fortune. On his belt was a sword and an empty holster of a pistol that may have been confiscated before he was allowed in, as if someone like the Lord Admiral would carry out the assassination himself. His cape gently touched the polished floor.

Behind him, like a shadow, Lady Ka walked whistling. She cast contemptuous glances at the guards with her only eye. The woman seemed extremely confident, as if she already knew what was going to happen and was thoroughly enjoying it. When people like her seemed happy, there was reason to worry. There was also that dread, huge wolf, walking obediently at his master's side. Entrapta was attracted to the beast, probably because of its numerous cybernetic enhancements. Apparently, even the years

spent with Hordak did not make this woman develop an instinct for self-preservation.

As she looked at the Lord Admiral, she saw something she had never seen in Hordak. The majesty befitting a true ruler. Even Horde Prime, though she didn't know him very well, exuded an aura of fear that came more from brutal military power than from a talent for leading others.

Glimmer had one too. She sat on the throne, exuding strength that none of her ancestors would be ashamed of , hopefully it would be enough against someone like the Lord Admiral.

„Welcome, Lord Admiral Felix Antares . I am Queen Glimmer Moonbright. Ruler of all Etheria, wielder of the power of the Moonstone and, soon, leader of the galactic alliance. What are you looking for on our planet.

Antares bowed to her politely, but not humbly. Whatever you say about him, he was a brave bastard if he stood up to the most powerful people on the planet, even though he was only with Lady Ka and that scary wolf.

„As Lord Admiral, I came here by the will of the authorities of the Pact Worlds and Veskarium to discover the source of the attack that was carried out on us twice five years ago.” he said with the strong and hard voice of someone used to speaking. „This region of the galaxy is known as the Ravaged Zone and was considered an unexplored and dangerous area. That's why I was entrusted with command of the Research and Exploration Fleet. When we arrived here, we found the ruins of an Empire built by a mad tyrant who was responsible for the deaths of countless sentient beings. He was, because we learned that he was annihilated by She-Ra, the heroine of the Universe. So, while my troops are conducting a stabilization mission, I have come here to discover the truth about this mysterious attack. But as Felix Antares, I came here for much more personal reasons.” now his voice softened, even became warm and softer. “For thirty years, since I and my people were expelled from our planet by treacherous

enemies, I have fought many enemies, including the most terrible of all, the Swarm. War does not help in starting a family, but sooner or later each of us comes to that moment when we start to think about our legacy and what we will leave behind. Until now I thought that I had been deprived of mine, but by an unimaginable twist of fate it turned out to be otherwise. Therefore, I would like to ask for one favor. – he knelt down on one knee and looked at Catra . – For the opportunity to be at my daughter wedding."

Absolutely everyone was frozen in disbelief. There was a possibility that the Lord Admiral was lying, but as she looked at the face features of the commander and her former ward, at the cold gleam in their blue eyes, she knew it must be true. *I turned out to be a blind Ignorant again. We are all doomed*

Danger surrounds us

When she saw the man kneeling in front of them, she was sure it didn't mean anything good, but when he said those words... She just froze. It was such incredible, impossible news that her mind couldn't process it. She looked at Catra. The Grand Marshal was standing with wide eyes and her knees trembling. Adora placed a hand on her shoulder and hugged her comfortingly. A shy smile appeared on her shining face. She shook her head and said in a sharp tone.

„What you said is absolutely impossible. For the past millennia, Etheria has been cut off from the rest of the Universe. During this time, no one... almost no one came here." She glanced at Adora.

Antares smiled slightly and said.

„However, I am absolutely sure that Catra is my child. How she got here is a mystery we must discover. We can perform appropriate genetic testing if you wish."

She was about to shout that there was no question of any tests, but then Catra spoke up.

„He's right..." her friend said quietly and looked at the others. "I was not born on Etheria."

She blinked and looked at her friend. Was this some ridiculous joke? Adora looked at her fiancée in surprise.

„We've known each other forever. You are present in my oldest memories." Adoea said in disbelief.

„ Almost forever." Said the Grand Marshal in an increasingly monotonous voice. „ Remember how you told me you found me in an applesauce box? Or maybe you know about it because Shadow Weaver told us about it? I must have gotten here not long before

this happened. I did genetic testing before the wedding and it turned out that you are not from here. That's why I asked for the Fright Zone record. I didn't find any of them, but then I looked at the box and it said it was made in a place called Kesler.” her voice was on the verge of breaking down. “I think that's where I was born.”

Then the Lord Admiral spoke.

„I know Kesler, or rather I knew. It's a planet that has been devoured by the Swarm. I had one of my greatest victories near her. However, you were not born there, but on Atrax located in the same system, which I defended against the Swarm invasion. At one time, Kesler was a large food exporter, so a box with products coming from there is nothing strange... I apologize for the poor choice of words, but it was also a extraordinary experience for me.”

She noticed that when Atrax was mentioned, Catra's ears twitched as well. Has she also heard about this place? She touched her temple, wondering what she should do now. Nothing had prepared them for this news. In the afternoon she heard about the existence of the Fleet, and at night she met its commander claiming to be Catra's father. Damn, more likely. she would have expected to meet Adora's family. And then there was the thing with her mother… No, there was a limit to the amount of world-changing news that could be received in a day. She sighed and said.

„We need to confer. The news you have brought is extraordinary and we must now consider what steps we should take next.”

The Lord Admiral nodded in understanding. This man looked completely different than she expected from a non-Etherian military man, but then again she had no idea what she should expect from someone like that. He did not resemble Hordak in any way, much less Horde Prime . He wasn't nearly as bitingly arrogant as Catra's former superior, nor half as insanely conceited as a mad tyrant. He seemed patient and composed, like a soldier

on briefing waiting to get back to his job. She couldn't say how old he was, she assumed he was her father's age, but she wasn't sure. He certainly looked like a true soldier who did not hesitate to lead his men in battle. He seemed respectable, but... there was something about him that she didn't like, as if there was a deep-seated ferocity more suited to the wolf standing by his side. She could be sure of one thing. There was a visible resemblance between him and Catra, especially in the glow of his blue eye.

Entrapta approached the large wolf-like creature with genuine interest and tried to touch it with her hair, but when the half-cybernetic monster looked at her, she behave unusually cautious and asked.

„Could I watch it? I've never seen a creature with so many cybernetic modifications."

The woman in the half mask smiled at her with only half of her mouth visible, it was a particularly nasty smile, and said.

„Sure." said women In halfmask and when the inventor approached the wolf, she added. "If you think you have too many limbs."

The inventor stopped mid"move and the Lord Admiral looked sharply at the masked woman and said.

„This is Lady Ka, my intelligence and information officer. She has a specific sense of humor." he placed his hand on the wolf's head. „ As long as I'm around, Resh won't hurt you, but I'd be careful around other nightmare hunters. They are creatures created for fighting."

A specific sense of humor she thought incredulously, and then added.

„I will soon give orders for you to be assigned rooms in the castle." her voice was as tired as she was. She felt like she was about to fall asleep on her own, but she still had a serious meeting with her friends waiting for her today. Of everyone

gathered in the throne room, only John Killthem looked happy, and that didn't bode well.

She sat in a chair with her eyes closed and her head tilted back. She tried to use these few precious minutes to gather her thoughts, but her mind went blank. She didn't feel anything. For the first time in as long as she could remember, no emotions tugged at her dark soul. There was no fear, no anger, not even guilt. Only numbing silence. But it couldn't last long. She was aware of the crew members of this ship looking at her, asking "What next?" Only she didn't know the answer. *If Eti hadn't wanted to be so damn melodramatic, if Itel hadn't wanted to break into the castle... If I hadn't come up with a date... Bina, why did you entrust the care of these kids to someone whose parenting methods amount to tormenting and manipulation.* She thought, although it all didn't matter now anyway. During this journey, she had to admit very often how little she knew. But she couldn't tell those kids that. She had to think of something, and fast, that would give them some time to analyze the situation and decide what they should do next. She looked at Eti and said thoughtfully

„So you and Catra are his daughters... Who was... the second gene donor?”

Eti tilted her head to the side and said”

„Asera, Igzar's sister ... The same one who shot him... Although only after her death. He had her body taken away and then gave it to Jantar... Old bad Cat claimed that the Admiral found it funny to create offspring with the one who almost killed him. But I'm not so sure. It doesn't matter anyway... „ she looked at her with her absolutely calm, or maybe even sad, eyes, with blue sparks shining in them. “But you're not Miss Daisy. Or maybe she's not you.”

She sighed. She hoped it would never happen, even though she should have expected it. She once believed that she could complete the task unnoticed, without affecting the lives of the inhabitants of Etheri. But these were naive pipe dreams. Even before discovering the truth about the Lord Admiral, before learning Captain Moonshadow's identity, before meeting Eti, she should have known that the plans of a being like Nyarlathotep would change the lives of everyone and anyone who stood in their way. Or even just nearby. It was actually a selfish desire. Fear of facing the consequences of one's own actions. She was afraid of being judged for her crimes and se hatred in the eyes of Catra and Adora. She had a foretaste of this when she met Mikah.

„My name is Shadow Weaver, and my former name was Light Spinner" she replied in a tired, hopeless voice.

„So you were born here. You knew her, my sister, Catra ... „ Eti said, and the lack of emotion in her voice was downright painful.

„I was the right hand of Hordak , the brother of our Wrongdak, and one of the most important people in the Etherian Horde. I was no better than your... Your father, only I was less effective. I raised your sister, although this is a very euphemistic term...„ she said, and Eti nodded, obviously deciding not to pursue the topic, at least for now, although she was aware that she would not escape this conversation. Alatar and Lilka looked astonished, and Itel looked angry... But Rosie... She saw disappointment in the white-haired girl's bright blue eyes. She guess the former intern saw her as a role model, a mentor... especially after Dilayla left with Lady Cala . The deaf girl treated the mercenary like a older step-sister. She hoped she wouldn't lose it, although considering that the half"elf was traveling with Calamity , there was little chance of that happening.

„This conversation is probably needed by all of you, but unfortunately I must ask you to postpone it until later, because we have limited fuel resources, and I would like to remind you that the last time we refueled was on Saltmarsh, and this ship has not had a full overhaul since Akiton .„ said Mr Ilemshaw. „We can drift

in space for a long time if we leave the planet, but in the atmosphere for a few hours at most. So I propose to everyone that we quickly find a safe haven.”

The fish-like alien was right, but the answer wasn't that simple.

„How many ships did the Lord Admiral take with him... „ Itel asked carefully.

„I'm not sure, but everything indicates that he came here on board a small ship, a corvette even smaller than ours.” Mr. Ilemshaw replied.

„So we can escape into space and hide there.” Alatar said, but Itel and Eti gave him contemptuous glances.

„We didn't come to this planet to hide again like those rats.” Itel growled at him. “ We just need to find a safe shelter and resume our search there. Do you know the right place.”

"I finally have to find out what you're looking for on this planet," she thought and replied.

„It's not that easy. Glimmer has the ability to teleport, as you may have already seen, and with a greater range than you might imagine. She also knows tracking magic, although your brother Wrongdak has figured out a way to block it. Still, it's unlikely she'll send Adora or the army after us.” “Unless she ascertains my involvement in all this” – However, there is one place he cannot go. Castle Crypto is no longer Entrapta's home, but from what I understand it is outside the Queen's rule and Glimmer has never been able to navigate there. We'll leave Mr. Wrongdak somewhere safe along the way.

But the clone shook his head.

„No... I'd rather stay here with you and see how it all ends. – he replied, and she added in her mind. "And still spy for your brother"

„And the Lord Admiral? Won't he chase Eti now when her sister tells him everything?” Itel asked, but she smiled bitterly and said in a low voice.

„ It's unlikely. Catra has always been distrustful. It's largely my... credit.”

They were in the Fireplace Room, where the fire had been rekindled. Now Glimmer stared into the flames and listened to her stories about her meeting with Queen Angela . Catra had asked for a moment to herself and was now sitting in the chair, covered with a blanket with Melog's head in her lap. Apart from them, buddies , there were only High Minister Shou and Onyx Sky.

„That's all I know... I'm sorry.„ She said and looked down, expecting bitter words, even screams and maybe even insults. But when Glimmer turned to her, she saw that her eyes were full of tears, which she expected, but she was smiling happily, which she was completely unable to understand.

„It's wonderful! I haven't been this happy in years.” she said, swallowing tears

„Glimmer… Did you hear what I said? Your mother is a pirate, she was in some prison camp before and lost her arm. She hates me because all this happened to her because of me! Why aren't you mad! You should.” she felt tears flowing down her cheeks.

„I know it's terrible, but you must understand, she's alive! Is alive! This is the most important!„ exclaimed the queen with euphoria in her voice, and Bow added with a warm smile.

„Adora, listen. We don't know everything. I'm sure it can be explained! Remember when Glimmer was in Horde Prime's captivity? Or when Catra got chipped? We managed somehow then, and we can do it now.

She smiled slightly, although she did not share her friends' optimism. They didn't see the hatred in Angela's eyes. Catra then spoke from her lair.

„She stayed in the portal. Do you remember how different and strange that reality was? How did it change our memories? We don't know what she remembers now. Besides, I may have never met Queen Angela, but from what you told me, she wasn't a woman who blamed others for her choices.” her voice was quiet and sounded as if her girlfriend was exhausted to death.

„Oh, if it's a memory problem, I can fix it.„ Entrapta exclaimed with delight, jumping to her feet. Until now, she had been sitting quietly in the corner of the room, writing something down on a datapad, and it seemed as if she wasn't listening to them, but apparently that wasn't the case. “Hordak also lost a lot of his memory and I had to help him. I made him a machine that helped him regain his memory. After a month, the headache went away and the stepping of the mice stopped hurting him.”

„A month's hangover in exchange for regaining memory... A difficult choice.” Onyx Sky said, smiling shyly, trying to lighten the mood a bit.

„For now, we need to find out where she is... Do you think she will come here to Etheria?” Glimmer asked, staring at her questioningly. She thought about it and nodded.

„He'll almost certainly come here. She wanted my sword... That was probably the last thing she remembered from before she was imprisoned. – she felt a pang of guilt again, but Glimmer put a hand on her shoulder.

„Whenever she appears somewhere, I will teleport there and I will talk to her. She couldn't forget me, after all, I was her daughter. And maybe I'll take my dad...„ the queen smiled with delight.

„This isn't the best idea. To her, Mikah is dead. Seeing people we consider dead is very shoking to say the least... „ Catra said and

shuddered. “This might not end very well.”

Glimmer looked pointedly, Catra had mentioned her adventure in the library, although the walking dead were something straight out of a Shadow Weaver fairytales….

Glimmer finally sighed and nodded.

„You're right, it's better for dad not to find out that mom is alive. Just in case... „ she fell silent significantly. “And I guess we shouldn't tell anyone else about her. Let's just warn everyone about the marauding pirate, but let's not attack if she doesn't attack first... „ she said, but then Catra interrupted.

„Don't tell anyone about my sister either... especially this man.”

Glimmer, Bow and Entrapta's eyes widened and the Queen asked.

„What do you mean your sister... How...”

„That girl... That Eti... She is my sister, she told me thatherself... She is so similar to me, but also so different.” she said and described her meeting with this girl. Hearing this story, she herself opened her mouth wide, no less surprised than the others. When Catra was finished, she curled up in the blankets and seemed to be that little girl again, lost in the dark halls of the Fright Zone. Although not. In her eyes she didn't see the old despair and fear that had always accompanied her there, but rather hope, even if timid and unsure.

„That's... amazing Catra. You have a sister, a family... A little strange and unusual, but this is still a wonderful thing... Until they start stealing your things, following you around and crying when you don't let them... Jeez, I must have been a really terrible little brother.” Bow laughed and her fiancée smiled shyly and she joined her and said.

„This Eti is a nice girl, although a bit strange. She herself found me on Icarus, when I went hiking alone because... I wanted to take a break from people. She immediately offered me a place on

the ship. She was there with her friends. A Saihe girl named Itel and a deaf white-haired girl they called Rosie. Scorpia and Perfume encountered her remaining two friends, a winged lizard called Alatar, and a warrior girl named Lilka. There had probably been some sort of fight between them earlier, but when we met, they had already become friends. And Wrongdak was with them!”

Then Glimmer turned to her.

„Oh, have you met Wrongdak? Is he okay?” she asked, flapping her wings happily

„Nothing, even though he dresses so colorfully now so...„ she wanted to add, "that Hordak would start growling in irritation", but it might hurt Entrapta. “He was there with Emily, and from what he told me, those kids saved him from terrible danger. They're… nice kids. They probably also came from Kesler.”

Catra frowned.

„And we're back to this planet again... Or this system.” The cat girl rubbed her temples. “Tell me more about my sister. About this Eti.”

She smiled because it was definitely a more pleasant topic to talk about.

„She likes to sneak around and is talkative and whines a lot, but she is nice and her friends gave me some crisps. Quite tasty, although terribly fatty. She can also be a little weird. She asked me to board their ship instead of Lady Cala. She probably wanted to get rid of Lady Cala, although I don't understand why, because Lady Cala is... „ she couldn't find the right word to describe this woman. “She is beautiful and strong. She is… You just feel that she was created for great things. I spent a few minutes with her, but I had the impression that she would be a better She-Ra than me.”

Then Catra giggled.

„You're still really stupid sometimes, you know that? There is no better She-Ra, because she is you.” she smiled mockingly.

„If you meet her, you'll understand.” she replied to her fiancée, who snorted mockingly.

„I guess I should feel jealous.” Catra smiled flirtatiously at her and winked. She shook her head and began to explain.

„Her name is Lady Cala Grayskull and she claims that she may be a descendant of Mara.”

Hearing what Adora said, she flapped her wings and asked.

„That Mara? The previous She-Ra?”

Adora nodded.

„That's what she said. He comes from the planet Carurystal. But I don't know much else. She saw your mother... And she told me about what happened to her. I think they traveled for a while. They didn't even suspect who she might be.”

She closed her eyes and took a deep breath. Her mother was alive, but she became a pirate. She would have laughed once if she heard about it. Queen Angel is a Pirate? Could there be a more ridiculous idea? But now, after hearing Adora's story... Why did something so terrible happen to her? A woman who did so much for Etheria, sacrificed so much for everyone. It was so terribly unfair!

„Is it true?” she asked and, seeing Adora's questioning look, she added. “It's about Lady Cala.” she didn't even want to think about the rest. *My mother murdered a child. An innocent child. She has become as evil as the Shadow Weaver*

Adora hesitated.

„I'm not sure. She herself said that it could only be a legend passed down in her family. She doesn't look like Mara, but thousands of years have passed since then, who knows how much her family might have changed. I know almost nothing about Mara, apart from the few messages she left for me. I don't know if she could have had a child.”

„If that Lady Cala really is a First One descendant, that would explain why She was hanging around her.” Catra said, her voice quiet and pained, her two colored eyes seeming to be staring at something others could see, perhaps the past that was so terrible.

„She? Who are you talking about?” she asked, although something in the back of her mind told her she knew who she was talking about. The couple exchanged glances and Catra spoke slowly and carefully.

„Then, when I was chasing Eti, I saw shadows. The same ones she summoned, and when my sister disappeared, she was taken by a dark figure that looked like she was shrouded in darkness. I'm not entirely sure, but it could have been her.” This time she cringed, but Adora sat down next to her and hugged her. Then she said.

„I saw them too... On Icarus. These shadows. It was after the fight with that ship of Queen Angela and at that time I thought it was just hallucinations caused by fatigue and stress, but after that Catra said...

She sighed heavily. Shadow Weaver was the last person who they needed now.

„This is terrible. Today I thought it was good that she wasn't here. What do you think she might be looking for here? Is she behind this break-in?”

Catra jumped to her feet and Melog glowed red.

„I have no idea, but Glimmer, she has my sister. You understand? SHE HAS MY SISTER.” The cat-like girl shouted, wagging her tail

violently. Adora walked up to her and put her hand on her shoulder.

„I talked to these kids, dear, and they were wild and belligerent, but also confident and happy, not at all like someone raised by Shadow Weaver… Not like us. They seem to have their own guardian, a woman named Bina. She screamed at them when it turned out that they had left the ship without permission. Lady Cala and her companions seem to only be traveling on one ship. I think they even mentioned that they had a sorceress or two on board. One is called Miss Daisy, I think”

She involuntarily let out a short laugh, even though she wasn't happy. Catra looked at her, surprised and a little irritated.

„What is it about?”

She looked at both girls in surprise and said.

„Oh, you don't know that?! She once told me that her favorite flowers are daisies.”

There was silence, and only after a long moment did Catra speak firmly.

„ What we are going to do with it? We cannot allow her to roam Etheria unstoppable and continue to harm everyone.”

„I know how much she hurt you... no, no one knows that except you, but understand. She's still just one woman, with no support or allies.” She answered calmly.

Then Adora spoke up.

„You don't know what she is like! He's probably already weaving his intrigues in the shadows. You can't underestimate her.”

„They're right, honey.” Bow joined the conversation. “Even when she was on our side, she manipulated everyone to get what she wanted. Even you. And all she wanted was power.”

She sighed and began rubbing her wing thoughtfully.

„You're probably right, she was always nice to me only because she needed me. Maybe we'll let a few people know, like my dad, but if she's with your sister, we'll have to be careful if we still want to keep her existence a secret. „ she looked at Catra again. „There's also the matter of your father.”

Catra flattened her ears.

„Don't look at me like that. I've known him as long as you, actually less than Glimmer, because you heard about his exploits on Taurus. I... Just a few hours ago I was one of the many orphans of the Horde, and now I have a sister who tried to break into the castle, perhaps on the leash of the mangy woman who almost fucked up my life, and a father who came here with his own war fleet. So don't ask me what to do, because I don't fucking know”

Everyone in the Hall looked at the Great Marshal. Everyone in Brightmoon knew she didn't usually swear, so if she started doing it, it must have been serious. The first silence that followed the cat girl's outburst was Entrapta.

„We should establish cooperation with the fleet and the rest of the universe as soon as possible. I can't wait to learn about their discoveries. Can you imagine what technological development must have taken place there when thousands of worlds could exchange knowledge!” she clutched her hair, squealing in joyful ecstasy.

„That woman, Lady Ka, looked like she would love to feed you to that wolf.” Bow said, but the inventor waved her hand.

„There was always something trying to eat me on Beast Island, so I don't see a problem with that. I got used to.” Entrapta explained, apparently not understanding what the techmaster meant . Adora said thoughtfully.

„This woman, Lady. Ka, she looks very much like Bina. I don't know if they're twin sisters or maybe... Clones, but they must be related in some way."

Catra snorted in irritation.

„Sure, it's all connected, and there's a Shadow Weaver sitting in the middle, like that spider weaving its web of shadows."

She looked at her friend with concern. She knew from Scorpi that under stress she had bouts of paranoia.

„Maybe it is, but we don't know. For now, we need to find out more. This man, the Lord Admiral, I don't like him. He is too dangerous and at the same time he looks too noble... He is like a hero from a story. A noble and righteous commander who leads a noble army in the fight against evil. This is too thoughtful. Real people aren't like that."

„But." Catra interrupted her, looking suspiciously.

„But we might need it." she sighed and began to explain to her astonished friends. We won against Horde Prime, it's true, but we have been fighting his heirs for five years, but we have achieved nothing during this time, and our enemies are getting stronger. We have ships, a hell of a lot of ships, but no one to command them, and Adora and the other princesses can't be everywhere. He liberated Taurus within a week, something we have been planning to do for two years. If we are to form our Galactic Alliance, I must ask you to try to get closer to him since he wants to be your father anyway. After all, I could be wrong, he really is who he wants to appear."

Catra squinted and stared at the flames for a few moments as Melog glowed with all the colors of the rainbow. Finally she sighed and said in a flat tone.

„My sister told me... not to trust him, and I think we all guess it was about the Lord Admiral. However, if she is traveling with Shadow Weaver... She is deceitful and loves to manipulate others.

She could have turned her against him, as she did with us cadets all our lives... You're right, we need to find out more.” now her voice began to gain passion. “He can be an enemy or an ally, or both at the same time. But I want to know him because I want to know myself. To understand who I truly am and how much of that was instilled in me by Shadow Weaver.” She looked at her hands. Her claws were extended to their maximum length. “You know, those claws always made me feel safe. They were something that even Shadow Weaver and Hordak couldn't take from me. My sister... She lost her right hand, but her left hand... she was declawed... in a cruel way. She claimed an evil woman did it... If I find out it was Shadow Weaver, I swear I'll rip her throat out the first chance I get, and no one will stop me.” she drawled and looked at them, a cold flame burning in her blue eye.

...But won't bring us down

Arkan-tar stretched contentedly and dressed. The strix host couple who had made his night pleasant had long ago got up to run their inn. Waiting for him in the Main Hall were a gloomy Rechiza, a strangely self-satisfied Dilayla, and Doctor Quin , who was sitting at a table in pajamas and a nightcap, taking a nap.

„Lady Cala still sleeping?" he asked, sitting down at the table. Rechiza gave him an offended look and said.

„She went out in the evening and hasn't come back yet."

"And if the gods are kind to us, it won't come back." said the mercenary , stretching and smiling.

„"I wouldn't count on it." said Lashunti. Something interesting must have happened yesterday.

„Are you talking about the fact that he won't come back or about the grace of the gods." Dilayla asked, smiling, but Rechiza responded with a hard look.

„I have a vague feeling that I missed something yesterday. You slept together, right?" he asked, but both women looked at him in such a way that a cold sweat broke out on his back.

„Nothing, it just turned out that Miss Daisy was the right hand of the leader of the local Horde faction, you know, our Wrongdak's brother." the half-elf explained. He was silent for a moment, trying to absorb what he had just learned, until he finally spoke.

„How did you come to such an interesting conclusion?"

Dilayla sighed heavily and replied with irritation.

„I took it and read the tea leaves. What the fuck do you think?” and then she started to explain everything to him. Well, Arkan-tar called himself a scholar, someone who always had an answer to every question. Maybe not always sensible, often wrong, but at least that which sounds smart. So, as he sat there now, staring at Dilayla with his mouth open, he didn't feel comfortable with it. At first he had no problem accepting that the Lord Admiral was a war criminal, having worked for people of this type many times, Then he met the inhabitants of the Zone, who were ordinary, although fate-tested beings trying to lead normal lives... And everyone was impressed Etheria as if it were a wonderful place full of amazing heroes... And in the end it turned out to be. They even had their own avatar of Iomadae, or whoever this She-ra was. And of course she had to be friends with those strange Bina kids. Is it normal for demigoddesses to wander around the meadows and hang out with random kids? Apparently it is, well he didn't know anything about demigoddesses and kids, he was just a damn scholar after all. Then Captain Moonshadow went crazy and suddenly decided that she wanted her sword, but Adora probably broke it, but she claimed that the Pirate was the queen, which probably surprised the pirate and apparently upset her, because right after that she tried to burn down the city, which he wouldn't have been so concerned about, if it weren't for the fact that he was staying in this city. Then Adora, or should he say She-Ra, revived the kid, confirmed that Moonshadow was the queen, and left. On the ship, the situation returned to normal, Dr. Quin gave them a very interesting scientific lecture on the history of the Galactic Horde, which, however, had no significance for their current situation. Etheria herself turned out to be decidedly more likeable. The planet seemed to be a veritable treasure trove full of ancient artifacts and ancient technology that would keep him employed for the rest of his life, and probably beyond. Plus, it was quite a nice place, as he had the opportunity to see tonight, even if it was a bit rustic. However, when they reached the city, they saw this poster with an invitation to the wedding, where it turned out that some scared version of Eti was marrying Adora, which surprised everyone, except for the mercenary, who learned from Bina that Eti had a sister here. He wasn't that worried about this

discovery, although if he had known that the crazy cat girl had relatives in the government of this planet, he would have tried to befriend with them somehow. Of course, who in their right mind could have guessed that a bunch of war orphans could have anything to do with a planet that had been hidden from the rest of the universe for a thousand years. It hurt him a bit that this mercenary found out about everything, but on the other hand, it has long been known that sex connects thinking beings. However, what she learned now changed things completely.

Miss Daisy, that damned gloomy drunk, was a member of the Etherian Horde, in fact one of its main commanders. He's been to places where just staying in the same room with an enemy of the state could get you shot in the head, and they fucking brought her here. Even if the local rulers were very understanding, he could probably say goodbye to the permission to open the excavations. He would be very lucky if he managed to leave this planet free... And there was also the matter of Lady Cala.

Now he came to the conclusion that what he now learned explained many things. The dark mystic probably found the aristocrat herself, attracted by her mystical origins. Or maybe she invented this story herself and convinced the noblewoman that she was a descendant of this Mara, so that she could return to her planet. The point was that Lady Cala didn't seem like the kind of person a stranger could convince of anything. She was an intelligent and self-confident woman, not a naive rich girl longing for life like in penny novels. How much did she know about her mentor and tutor? They couldn't ask her about it directly.

„Rosie was drawn to this woman. I even thought that she had a crush on her, as orphans are wont to do, but she was simply clever, although dumb. She wanted to be friends with someone so powerful because she hoped that she would never have to work again. Well, if they lock her up in jail, she'll be able to laze around until she dies. But you know what? I don't feel sorry for her at all. Not only did she force a humble and poor scientist to give her hard-earned money for doing nothing, but now she practically abandoned me to death on this planet cursed by Angels and

Demons, where they don't even have an internet.” said the scientist, and Dilayla stared at her as she spoke, as if she wanted to grab her head and squeeze it until it burst like a ripe fruit. Maybe her relationship with that deaf girl wasn't so innocent? “However, I do not see any connection between our mystic's origin and our work, although I admit that if I knew the truth, I would ask her about the most interesting places on this planet.” Ysoka added and took a large sip of coffee. “THAT DRINK VERY GOOD. ME WANT MORE! MUCH MORE” she said to slowly and loudly to the landlady, who gave her the murderer a look.

„If you keep talking to the locals like they're idiots, they 'll start spitting into your plates, and ours as well.” Rechiza growled and added. “And if it turns out that we brought here a criminal who, let me remind you, was very cruel to the demigoddess and her fiancée, we will all be fucked.”

„Not to mention this.” Dilayla added in a quieter voice. “That we brought the bloody Lord Admiral here with his war fleet.”

Arkan-tar smiled slightly and also spoke in a low voice.

„Fortunately, it won't be easy to connect us and this man. Even if Miss Daisy spills the beans, it's not certain that anyone will believe her.” he took a sip of the sweet juice, first checking to see if there was anything floating in it. „The more important question is what we will do with Lady Cala now, because I guess pretending that nothing happened and everything can stay as it was is probably not an option.

„Why not, I can forget about everything I heard here as soon as I eat breakfast. When necessary, I can compromise with the truth.” said the Rat woman . As soon as she mentioned breakfast, it was brought immediately. It consisted of dried and candied fruit, nut paste, wholemeal bread and savory muffins.

„But will she let us forget about everything?” Dilayla said. “If he finds out that we suspect something, she may want to silence us all.”

This time, Arkan-tar rolled his eyes.

„Let's be serious, none of us probably suspects this woman of murderous tendencies.” he said with amusement, but the half”elf looked at him very seriously, as if she was a bit scared.

„I don't suspect her, but I know perfectly well that she has murderous tendencies. Shadow herself…Miss Daisy herself told me this to my face. Besides, you haven't seen her training fight. I, who have spent my entire life in war, know that I could not cope with it, even if she fought me with her bare hands and I was wearing power armor.”

„And who supposedly beat her then, because I heard she got hit, although I don't know who she was training with at the time.” he asked, chewing on some fruit similar to a grape, although more floury.

„With Rosie.„ the mercenary said, and then Dr. Quin burst out laughing, which Dilayla pointedly ignored. He himself smiled slightly.

„Do you know what I think, my dear Dilayla? You just liked this women, but she rejected you and now you're making up some ridiculous stories in revenge.”

He must have overdone it a bit, because the mercenary clenched her fists and stood up as if she was about to punch him with a cybernetic fist, but Rechiza signaled her to stop and spoke to him in a voice as sharp as Kasatha's sword.”

„ Don't measure us by your yardstick. Some of us think about our responsibilities, not just our pleasures”

„Are you jealous?„ He said and immediately regretted it, because a wave of chaotic magic from the Warper hit him.

„I am taking part in this expedition by order of the Lictor of the Order of Eclipse. He ordered me to keep an eye on Miss Daisy, because apparently she was a cultist... Maybe she really is, but

I'm not so sure now. She doesn't seem to be someone who sincerely believes in anything, and if she really was such a powerful and important person, she should have created a real cult here, maybe even sold the entire planet to the dark powers... But Lady Cala... There were some signals that we didn't pay attention to earlier comments. Coldness in the relationship between her and her mentor, words and behavior that do not fit the image of a charming aristocrat, fighting skills worthy of the best warriors. She single-handedly defeated the entire Azlanti unit. There is something very wrong with her. I am a hunter and I have heard of many vile monsters hiding their monstrous nature behind a beautiful face. If she is one of them, we have a serious problem."

He looked at the ceiling. This day was looking quite good.

„And what are you going to do about it, my dear?" he asked in a tired voice. Then the women looked at him meaningfully. For a moment he wondered what they might be talking about, and when he understood, he leaned towards them and spoke in a low voice.

„You guys must be crazy... You want her... „ the unspoken word hung between them.

"If you want to do something illegal, do it without me.„ said Doctor Quin and put on headphones and played Shiren's pop.

„So tell me, smart guy, what choice do we have?" Dilayla asked, and he answered her with silence.

And then Lady Cala entered the inn. As always, she radiated beauty and magnificence. She smiled happily at them and said.

„I'm sorry I didn't come back last night, but I was invited to a very hot party. It lasted until the race itself. What are you doing here? Because you make it seem like you're up to something. – she giggled and, without waiting for an invitation, sat down next to them. He was very happy that as a Verthani he could control the

color of his face. His friends were surprisingly composed. Or rather, they were just behaving as they always did. Rechiza was gloomy, and Dilayla smiled mockingly at the aristocrat. Lady Cala, clearly pleased with herself, ordered a sumptuous breakfast and a bowl of quite pleasant-smelling apple cider. At one point, when she got up to go to the toilet, he saw that Rechiza had put some powder into her drink. When Lady Cala returned, she sat down and drank the entire glass of apple drink in one gulp, then hiccupped, laughed , and apologized. Rehiza looked at him with a little fear.”

"You didn't think it would be so easy, did you," Verthani thought to himself.

Calamity felt content. The night meeting went well. The cultists showed her the respect she was usually spared from, although the way they showed it was exceptionally… relaxing. Well, the followers of Shub-Nigurath knew how to enjoy life. Although she was not sure how much she could rely on them, the Mother of a Thousand Young often recruited followers from among those who were more interested in the pursuit of carnal pleasures than in faithful service, although it was the same with Nyarlathotep. The creeping chaos usually bribed its minions with promises of power beyond the reach of mere mortals, but many of them were not truly dedicated and served themselves first. All you had to do was look at Shadow Weaver to understand how pathetic and cowardly these power-hungry sorcerers are. Fortunately, now the ruler of shadows was already far away, trying to fulfill her plan. Maybe she will succeed, time and Yog-Sototch will tell.

As soon as she entered the inn, she immediately noticed that her companions were planning something, which only improved her mood even more. Although she planned to kill them from the very beginning, each hunt and fight was more interesting when the prey defended herself. It was like a game, and she always liked playing games, although she wished the stakes wouldn't be too high since her companions didn't pose much of a threat. Rechiza

was a good example. The poison she gave her caused a heart attack, but she had no heart, both figuratively and literally, although the organ pumping ichor in her body somewhat resembled one. They obviously didn't know its true nature, or weren't well enough equipped. If she had used Brevon, it would have caused her a much bigger problem. Even her regenerative abilities would have trouble dealing with such a deadly element, although it probably wouldn't kill her. But it could force her to stay in bed for several days, not to mention the radiation it would contaminate whatever she was wearing. For a moment, she was tempted to throw herself on the floor, pretending to have a heart attack, and point at Lashunti and shout, "It's her." She wonder what the locals would do with guests from an alien planet trying to poison one of their companions. The faces of the pathetic inhabitants of Etheri would be hilarious.

„However, I must admit that this night was not only about entertainment. I got us a means of transportation.” she said, devouring pasta with fruit. “Nothing special, three anti-gravity bikes. A certain general's daughter will lend them to us. Free… well, sort of. I promised I would go with her to Victory Day. All that remains is to discuss how we will divide the vehicles.”

„I'm taking Dr. Quin.” Dilayla said immediately.

„And I ride with Arkan-tar.” Rechiza hastily added. Ysoka looked at the half”elf and spoke in a serious, slightly cocky tone.

„I know that I'm extremely attractive, but restrain your lustful tendencies, because I'm only attracted to males and only from tailed species!”

The mercenary snorted with contempt. "Yes. They clearly suspect something, even if they knew the truth.”

Rechiza couldn't understand how the mercenary could sleep so peacefully after receiving such news. After all, what she learned

ruined the point of their entire trip. They let in on their plans a woman who must have had a hand in this attack... Did Dilayla not care about Rosie? Or maybe it was that military thing. Mercenaries must have learned to sleep always and under all conditions, because you never know when there will be another opportunity to do so. However, she had to admit that the mercenary had gained a lot in her eyes. She really started looking for a solution to the terrible situation they found themselves in. She even let her in on her plans, which sounded quite sensible.

However, Arkan-tar turned out to be a major disappointment. First he tried to make a joke out of it, and then he fell into a chair, completely helpless. How could someone like that be considered a scholar and traveler? Every righteous being knew that in such a situation he must remain focused and not be distracted if she wanted good to prevail. Fortunately, she suspected that People like Miss Daisy did not understand this simple rule.

Arkan-tar, of course, as soon as he found out that she was going with him, started imagining ridiculous things. He was, of course, an attractive and charming and well-educated man, but she didn't just think about those things. Even though she hadn't been with anyone since the accident, the loss of her antennae meant she couldn't feel things the way she used to, and she was afraid that being together would be a huge disappointment. The truth was that she didn't want to go with Lady Cala because the woman truly terrified her, especially after she drank a dose of poison that could kill three people. Whatever she was, they would find out sooner than they would like.

They left the town around ten o'clock in the evening. She had to admit that this planet was quite a nice place. She had never felt such clean air even on Castrowal. But it wasn't just the clean air that made this place so extraordinary. She felt the power permeating them through and through. It intoxicated her, like pure oxygen. The magic came from inside the planet, but not only that. She felt it from the moons too, but this time it was different. She didn't know how it was with technomancers and ordinary mystics, but she drew power from other planes and thanks to it

she was able to feel something amazing. These moons produced planar resonance. Everyone is different. For example, the black, barely visible moon resonated with the depressing despair of Abadon , while the fiery orange one radiated the resonance of fiery joy typical of Elysium. She had no idea whether the inhabitants of this place felt their influence in their daily lives, or whether she was even aware of their power. Unfortunately, she didn't have time to ask anyone. Animals were plentiful here, another thing that connected this place to her native Castrowal . She didn't look at many creatures, but from what she saw, some of them were surprisingly similar to those that were supposed to live on the lost Golarion, which wasn't that strange. Many of the terraformed planets were home to animals that once lived on that legendary planet, but most of them were colonized after the Gap, or not long before it ended, and Etheria would be cut off from the rest of the Galaxy for millennia. But what was she wondering about, since the inn was run by a very friendly couple, the Strix , and the Lashuntas lived in the jungle ... And their Grand Marshal looked almost like an unstable teenager they had brought here. Apparently the planet had already been partially terraformed before it was cut off from the rest of the Galaxy, and the colonizers, probably the Firsts ones, brought here a labor force gathered from all over the galaxy. But several animals looked different. They had many eyes that looked like they were made of jewels. She saw a small blue-furred mouse eating some fruit, probably of Golarion origin. It was interesting, although she doubted it would ever matter to them.

The vehicles were generally similar in structure to the skimmer in which they flew to the town. They were probably made by the local Horde, and she had to admit that they were surprisingly functional, although she suspected that the soft seats had been added here quite recently. Arkan-tar was a really good driver, and it was nice riding with him and having him around her waist felt good, though she would never admit it out loud. Dilayla rode with Dr. Quin , whom she strapped to her chest in a makeshift baby carrier. Lady Cala, of course, turned out to be an excellent pilot.

She moved ahead of their small group like a guide, and sometimes she waited for them, smiling broadly and joyfully, until it made her feel sick.

Eventually they reached the dry rainforest hills. The plants here were covered with countless thorns, although it was quite pleasant here. Dilayla divided the equipment between them and then they set off. The terrain was difficult and they had to leave their vehicles on the road, which did not please Dr. Quin , who complained about her painful joints. Well, traveling with Ysokis and scientists at the same time had its share of problems. During this journey, they often strayed from the established path, as if the forest itself was trying to get in their way. She used to wander the wilderness of the Pact Worlds very often, before... the accident, but since then she had mainly been conducting investigations or research and had lost some of her stamina, which caused her to often stop and gasp, but she tried not to complain. Dilayla, of course, had no problems in her armor, although she would have been fine in a swimsuit. She finally decided to strap Doctor Quin to her armor using the carrier she had used earlier, probably so that she wouldn't have to hear her grumbling and whining anymore and so that she wouldn't delay her march. Arkan-tar was, of course, fresh and rested, apparently his nightly activities had not tired him. And Lady Cala… well, she was tireless. She jumped over boulders and stones like a rock drake, and the vines and bushes did not pose the slightest obstacle to her, she chopped them with powerful blows of the machete. She suspected she would have chopped off their limbs with the same verve and smile. She shuddered at the thought.

At one point, Arkan-tar approached her. There was an inherent happy smile on Verthani's face , as if the morning conversation had not taken place.

„Help you? You look exhausted.” he suggested, but she glared at him furiously.

„Oh, you want to play gentleman saving a lady in trouble? I can handle!”

„Not every woman can be Dilayla... Personally, I'm glad she is n't because my nightlife would be much more boring.” Verthani chuckled, which irritated her even more. “You're the one who does magic, and it would be unfortunate if you fainted just as you were supposed to fight off Leukodaemon”

She bit her lip and said in a low voice.

„Maybe she's the best of us because she's the only one who still cares about anything. We hide behind our Mission, even though we don't really know what it is now, allowing someone like Anatares to roam this corner of the galaxy, so terribly tried by evil and tyranny . And it's not going too well for us, because we don't give a damn about anything so much that we brought a damn witch and a monster here, damn... „ she stopped and looked around with frightened eyes. “Due to our ignorance, we probably sentenced Rosie, Bina and her kids to death or maybe something worse. I won't even be sorry if our noble aristocrat cuts us into pieces!” at the end of her statement she almost screamed, then adjusted her backpack and moved forward, although only Eloritu knew how much her back hurt.”

The phrase she hated most in the world was "I told you so." But she could use it to describe the entire day today. Arkan-tar and Rechiza did not take kindly to the news of who they had been traveling with all this time. Rechiza acted as if she was offended by reality, and Arkan”tar simply denied the inconvenient facts. And Dr. Quin just didn't care. She never wanted to be anyone's moral compass, but clearly she had to. She was only happy that the Warper was willing to cooperate, and even tried to poison Lady Cala , albeit unsuccessfully. She wasn't sure if there was any poison in the galaxy that could kill such a nasty viper...

The terrain was becoming more and more mountainous and it was more and more difficult for them to climb, especially the Warper had trouble continuing her journey, but she didn't ask anyone for help, not even Verthani , for whom she clearly felt something, so

she didn't lean out. Dr. Quin snored happily strapped to her armor, completely oblivious to the shocks. She kind of envied her ability to ignore problems.

Finally they reached the top of a not very high, very flattened mountain. There were many boulders and a stone obelisk decorated with images of a monstrous creature, somewhat similar to a nightmarish, humanoid version of the Golarion elephant.

„What kind of madness is this?" the mercenary asked with disgust.

„ It's Chaugnar Fhagn, Horror From The Hills. Apparently Bina's scanners led us to the temple of the Great Old One." Rechiza muttered, a strange mixture of relief and disgust in her voice.

„No, that can't be it. The statue was created quite recently. Traces of erosion indicate that it was no more than three or four hundred years ago, and using the simplest tools. We are looking for something that resembles traces of a highly developed civilization. The First Ones, as far as is known, were not worshipers of the Great Old Ones, or any other beings for that matter. This was probably built here because the locals remembered that this place was associated with the First Ones and wanted to capture a piece of their splendor by building their temple here. Or they left a statue of such a terrible creature here to oppose another, equally great evil. "Arkan-tar explained, continuing to look around."

„The First Ones are generally considered a noble race serving good, it is highly doubtful that anyone sees evil in them." Rechiza said uncertainly and winced as she unconsciously touched her cybernetic eye.

„An Angel for some will be a Demon for others." Lady Cala said, and on this one occasion she agreed with her wholeheartedly.

They stopped for a while and Dr. Quin began to examine the area using one of her devices, as she said, looking for a disruption in the structure of the magical network. About fifteen minutes later she approached one of the many mounds of stones and said.

„Hmm... Strange...”

„More strange than the image of an Eldritch monster?” she said in a sarcastic tone.

Ysoka waved her hand.

“Sure. I've seen something like this on TV many times. And here something is sucking in the micromagic waves I am sending, instead of simply bending them, as it should be done.

“So that means there's a place out there that we need to get to?” the mercenary asked, and when Ysoka nodded, she told everyone to stand back and fired several times from her shoulder-mounted cannon. After a few volleys she managed to loosen the stones and walked over to them and using the force provided by the power armor began to move them apart. Then Lady Cala rolled up her sleeves and said.

„I'll help you.” she started working with the mercenary. It didn't escape anyone's notice that the aristocrat was as strong as a woman in modern power armor, but no one commented on it because there was no point. Everyone knew what that meant anyway. Soon they saw a tunnel covered with a substance resembling a crystal.

„Let's go.” said Dilayla, feeling the battle excitement in her stomach.

The corridor was wide and illuminated by the soft glow of the crystals. Rechiza walked timidly next to the mercenary, looking uncertainly at the walls, which were covered with star-like inscriptions, similar to those in the monastery.

„The node of the northern part of the Adamantium Soul planetary defense system.” the Warper explained in a muffled voice. She was terrified. As far as the mercenary knew , it was related to an accident that resulted in her losing her eyes and antennae. She understood her. Even she, a veteran of many wars clad in extremely resistant armor, gave chills, let alone a fragile Warperr.

Arkan-tar examined his surroundings carefully, apparently more used to this type of place than the others. Lady Cala, on the other hand, seemed fascinated. It was one of the few times she acted true to the image she was trying to project. After all, this was a place created by her ancestors. And Dr. Quin just seemed disappointed

They finally reached a huge room with lots of pink crystals mounted in the walls. In the middle there was a ten-meter-wide pillar covered with an exceptionally dense network of inscriptions in the First Ones language. The pillar was hollow inside and there was a recess inside it. It looked like a place where you could put an object, perhaps a battery or some kind of generator to provide power to the entire complex. There were numerous lines branching out from it, though she didn't understand their purpose, but well, that wasn't her job.

„It's probably a geomantic network, I wonder what they were used for...” Rechiza started , but then she stopped and started trembling. She raised her right hand and pointed to the shape resting against the opposite wall . It resembled a combination of a millipede and a sea spider with countless limbs.

„I think he's inactive, but we have to be very careful, because if he wakes up, we'll be screwed.„ said Arkan-tar. Everyone, even Lady Cala, nodded.

„It says there that one branch leads to the terminal of some Heart Gift Planetary Archive , and the other to the planetary node control center. Maybe let's go in the other direction first.” Rechiza said in a hushed whisper.

Arkan-tar and Lady Cala nodded and they all headed towards the chosen branch. However When they were very close, Lady Cala jumped back and said with false sadness in her voice.

„Well, I was originally planning to give you a much more... Sophisticated death, but this one will be much more practical... I won't ruin my dress... oh , you're not surprised! I blew a joke!”

The aristocrat giggled and dodged Dilayla's shot very neatly. She then pulled out her plasma gun and shot at the mechanical monster. Rechiza screamed as the creature moved. But then Dilayla held out her hand, which held a detonator of explosives. Lady Cala's eyes widened as she realized what had happened, and with a movement so fast that the mercenary could barely see, she threw the backpack in which Dilayla had previously placed their explosives towards them. The half-elf immediately set off the fuse, but the backpack was already flying towards them. The explosion blew both Ich and Lady Cala back. The vault began to collapse, and then darkness fell.

The force of the Explosion would have killed a more pity creature on the spot, but it threw her against the wall. It burned part of her body and ripped off her arm, which was only a minor inconvenience, but it also ruined her dress, something she would never forgive those filthy worms. She didn't think these creatures could afford such treacherous perfidy. However, she should show off less and watch them more. Sometimes Shadow Weaver's words contain wisdom, she should probably listen to it sometimes... even though it was so... irritating.

She didn't feel pain the way normal mortals did. She couldn't lose consciousness either. Even when she slept, she was actually listening to the music of the universe that her divine parent hummed. So all she could do was wait for her body to recover sufficiently until she could take any action. The eyes were the first to regenerate, the sense organs were always among the first to return to functionality. She saw that the tunnel containing these traitorous scum was collapsed, so she smiled with what was left of her mouth. The explosive was much closer to her than to them when it detonated, so there was a chance they wouldn't die instantly. She hoped that they were now lying there on the other side, waiting for a slow death by starvation... Although perhaps she would find another, much more interesting use for them. For their wickedness, they did not deserve an easy end. Fortunately, the local runestone site remained intact. While these artifacts

have lost much of their former usefulness, her bloodstone nerve core will thus be able to tap into the planet's geomatic grid and create its own crystalline grid. Everything was going according to plan, but then she saw movement. The mechanical guard stirred and woke up. By the tentacles of Shub-Niggurath ! This creature could be a real problem. She wasn't sure she could beat him. A similar one once almost killed an enhanced She-Ra, until Shadow Weaver had to give up her worthless life and call upon the power of an Outer God to defeat him. Although it was not easy to kill her, a few cells were enough for her to regenerate, although it was a long process, and even then, there was a chance that she would lose some of her freshest memories, but imprisoning her was devastatingly easy. She had to get away from this beast as quickly as possible, get out of here! She tried to get up and run out of there, but her body failed her. That was weird. After taking such damage, her regeneration must have been slower, but something else was slowing her down, probably the power drain that that stupid rodent had mentioned. She fell over with a nasty splat, and then the creature turned towards her. She cursed, got up and started running. She knew she wouldn't make it to the exit, but there was this side branch leading to that planetary archive. Maybe she'll make it. She tensed all her muscles and jumped. If she were like the mangy worms she had traveled with so recently, she would have lost her head, but her supernatural dexterity only caused him to lose a few strands of hair. Any damage to her perfect body, even the slightest, was a crime worthy of the utmost punishment, but now was not the time. She quickly crawled deeper into the corridor to keep the creature from reaching her. The mechanical monster couldn't get through here. She stood up, smiling with almost regenerated lips. Well, maybe she would be trapped here for a while, but even though she couldn't use real magic, she knew an ancient art that was deadly to mortals, but for someone as great as her, it was just a friendly arrangement. He only needs to wait a moment and then he will summon some servant of the Old Ones, or he will travel through the cursed plateau of Leng or the Land of Dreams

And then hundreds of smaller mechanisms similar to it began to descend from the mechanical guard's body, rushing towards her with the obvious intention of tearing her to shreds.

„Seriously?” she shouted, crushing the nearest crab spider with her foot and running into the room. Being torn apart by such tiny creatures. She bought some time. She found herself in a narrow room with several armchairs, which, according to the creators, were probably comfortable. She looked around, this would be an extremely idiotic end for someone like her!

„Hello! How can I serve you?” asked the hologram figure that suddenly appeared next to her.

„Who are you?” She asked, surprised by the appearance of a new creature. She could already hear the wave of mechanical crab spiders approaching.

„I am Heart Gift, planetary archive. I just found out that Mara and Light Hope were my moms, isn't that amazing?” Hologram said with Pure Delight.

„Indeed... „ she replied with sincere astonishment. But then she saw the robotic bugs coming and said.” Is there any way you can stop them?

„ I don't know if I'm allowed. Light Hope... my mother told me she forbade me from influencing defense programs. Geart said carefully Gift .

„Your mother certainly wouldn't be happy if you allowed an innocent creature to get hurt.” she said, jumping on a chair to avoid being torn to pieces. Heart Gift thought about her words for a moment, then waved her hand and all the creatures first froze and then began to retreat. Once the danger was averted, she looked at the hologram girl. Shadow Weaver had mentioned Light Hope to her, although honestly she didn't know much else about her. She knew that she was the planetary interface overseeing the Heart of Etheria project and was the mentor of the previous She-

Ra. As the presence of the creature standing next to her indicated, they were much closer. This can be used very creatively. She bowed as courtly as she could and said a friendly word.

„Thank you very much, Heart Gift, for saving my life. My name is Lady Cala Grayskull . My friends... they are probably dead or missing and now I am very lonely... Would you be willing to be my friend”

The holographic girl looked at her for a moment, then triggered holographic fireworks and jumped up and down happily.

„I have my first friend!”

Part Four - Princes of Nothingness - Family Matters, part one

Chapter Notes

> I would like to ask my readers to comment on my work, if you like it, it would give me strength to continue working on it.

She was lying on the border between wakefulness and sleep and was purring, cuddled up to Adora . She had several moments in her life when she wanted to stay in this blissful state, because she knew that as soon as she opened her eyes, she would have to face the terrifying reality. This was the case after Adora left the Fright Zone or when she was kidnapped by Horde Prime. This time, however, it was different. She had her friends who would help her face any danger that came her way. She was no longer alone against the world.

But this time it was different in another way too. The danger was much less obvious, perhaps it wasn't there at all. She didn't know if this man was truly a threat to them, or that Shadow Weaver was actually returned. After all, in such a large universe, there could be hundreds of sorcerers wielding shadow magic who had probably never even heard of the dark sorceress. Now, in the daylight, the idea that this evil woman had risen from the dead seemed like one of those stupid campfire stories. Her father didn't have to be a bad person, and besides, the line between good and evil wasn't always so obvious. She knew it best herself. However, something else was different than last time. Now she was in the center of all events and it was up to her how everything would unfold. The fate of everyone rested on her shoulders. She looked at her beloved, who was sleeping soundly, snoring loudly, and thought. *So that's how it is… How do you deal with it, my love. With this weight crushing you to the ground?* But she knew the answer. She couldn't cope at all, it wasn't something that could be

dealt with. All you could do was fight to keep the weight from crushing you.

They didn't make love that night, they just fell asleep cuddling each other right away. It was already late, probably around four in the morning, and the day had been long and tiring. It was now about nine o'clock and her head was hurting. She was sleepy, but she had to get up. This will probably be much more difficult for Glimmer, the ruler of Etheria liked to sleep until noon and go to bed after midnight. To be honest, it was similar with her, only the queen was not used to the brutal wake-ups they were given in the Fright Zone. She leaned over her future wife to kiss her, but as soon as she moved, Adora opened her eyes in slight fear. Adora, contrary to what some might have thought, had a lighter sleep even than her. Sometimes she felt like she never allowed herself to fully relax

„We have to get up, beloved... „ she said sadly, although she was smiling. "Glimmer will probably want to discuss wedding matters with you, and I… . „She sighed, and Adora embraced her and started stroking her neck with her fingers, making her shiver."

„Maybe we can order breakfast in bed and lie there for a while."

She sighed heavily and wrapped her arms around her fiancée's waist.

„I'd love to, but I really can't... He's waiting for me... „ There was much more worry and anxiety in her voice than she wanted.

„He's been waiting for you for twenty years, nothing will happen to him if he waits for you another hour or two..."

„Are you going to eat breakfast for two hours?" she asked, baring her fangs. Her hand slid a little lower, to Adora's buttock.

„Not only breakfast, darling." said the heroine of the Galaxy and kissed her hard and long. When she finally interrupted her, she said.

„You're idiot, if we start making love now, we'll eat a big breakfast, after which we'll want to take a nap, and then when we get up, we'll start... taking care of ourselves again and we'll lie here until noon. Or straight to dinner.”

Adora giggled and said.

„I'm not idiot, but cunny girl!”

They laughed together, but then they got up and took a quick shower, then got dressed, kissed each other goodbye, and went their separate ways.

In fact, she was very hungry, yesterday she only ate travel rations and until noon, because she was preparing for the sumptuous welcome dinner that she and Glimmer would eat. Melog was waiting for her outside the door, for obvious reasons they preferred him not to sleep in their room, but in his own small room. The cat-like creature practically didn't need to eat, it fed on pure magic in the air, but it could sense when its mistress was hungry, so it was concerned. So she came up with an idea. She went to the kitchen and asked if the Lord Admiral had had breakfast yet, and when they said no, she ordered the cart of food back and went to where their new guest was supposed to be.

Antares was placed in a small guest house built in the outer part of the castle. It provided as much privacy as possible in Brightmoon . They had certainly been very hospitable towards the Admiral, but she wasn't sure if it was reasonable.

In front of the door of the cottage stood two guards and the woman, Lady Ka, who threw the knife and caught it as it fell. This must have been extremely irritating for the guards.

„Hey.” she said carefully, hoping not to disturb the other woman's rhythm, which could result in her hurting herself.

„Hello.” said Mrs. Ka and looked at her, smiling mockingly. “You have to wait a while because the Lord Admiral is taking a shower and shaving and stuff like that.”

She nodded and was silent for a moment because she wasn't sure what she could talk about with the other man's companion.

„So you are…„ she asked carefully, and Lady Ka replied cheerfully.

„His intelligence and information officer. His left better hand... The Lord Admiral is left-handed, probably like you.” the woman stopped throwing the knife and pointed to her left hand, which she was leaning on the food cart. She also looked this way. In the Horde, being left-handed was a bit of a handicap because everything was made for right-handed people, although it was Shadow Weaver who was most irritated by it. When she was learning to write, in a fit of meanness, even for her, she order her to tie her left hand behind her back so that she could write like any intelligent creature. Of course, she failed to achieve anything, as she always did when she tried to bend her to her will.

„So… how long have you been with the Lord Admiral.” she asked carefully, in a not very confident tone, because she had absolutely no idea what to talk about with this woman, if anything at all. But she could be a useful source of information about her... about the Lord Admiral. There was just something wrong with her...

„It depends on what you're asking, if you mean whether the Lord Admiral is my guy, then no, he's not, so if you and your fiancée would like a little experiment, I'm free.” said Lady Ka and winked at her.

„Experiment?” she asked, honestly shocked. She did not condemn such relationships, nor did most of the inhabitants of Etheria , even Sea Hawk's mother lived in such a relationship, but she was not used to such... straightforwardness.

„Ha! You blushed... I was just joking. Maybe the Lord Admiral isn't the type to kill you for sleeping with his daughter, but the gods

are guarding careful ones.” she said and giggled again. “As for your question, it will be about five years. Since the Fall of Kesler and the death of Jantar. My Father and creator.” she said and became thoughtful.

„Creators? In what sense?” she asked. She didn't like the sound of that word.

„Well, creators. He created us. We are his clones, just like Horde Prime's younger brothers, although our dad always introduced a few improvements and more.” she pointed to her breasts.

Instinctively, the fur on her tail stood on end, and Melog flashed a warning green-yellow. She didn't think there was room in the universe for another fuck like that.

„So he... That Jantar was some kind of your Horde Prime?” she asked with a mixture of pity and horror.

„Uh, no. Not this scale of power and madness. Our Father was the underworld boss on Atrax, and we, the Thousand Daughters, were his gang. Well. He was a cunning bastard, but in the end he ended up just like your Horde Prime... Although we turned out to be much more sensible than the long-eared ones.” she said, grabbing the knife tightly and throwing it at the tree, right next to a very cute squirrel “We killed him.” she looked at her sideways, and the visible half of her mouth twisted into a very nasty smile. “But please don't follow our example. It would be very difficult for me to find an equally good employer now.”

If Double Trouble had a child with Shadow Weaver, it would be like that woman... I don't like her she thought with Irritation. There was something nasty about Lady Ka. Something that brought back very unpleasant memories. Melog looked down at her, his hair all ruffled. He didn't like this woman either. She must keep an eye on this woman.

„I think the Lord Admiral has probably washed and is ready for breakfast...„ she said coldly. Lady Ka tilted her head to the side,

like a predator wanting to take a closer look at a newly encountered animal, and said unexpectedly happily.

„You really look like him!”

She blinked and touched the cat's ears reflexively.

„Really?” she said skeptically. “I didn't notice when I looked in the mirror recently.”

„Then look again, especially at the glow of the blue eye. But it's not about looks. You have something inside you. Something very familiar” she said and opened the door with her foot, and then in a slightly exaggerated, even mocking way, motioned for her to enter.

Lord Admiral Antares sat on the back porch, basking in the warm sunlight. He was happy, for the first time in years everything was going according to plan… No, that wasn't the right word. Yes, the war was going extremely well, although no one declared it to anyone, just like the realization of his more... personal ambitions. But what he found here… It changed everything. Until now, all his actions had been dictated by his desire to create a legacy that would last after his far too quick end, and to secure the future of his soldiers, but now… Now it turned out that there was another path, bright and clear. The destiny of the Antares family once again lay before him bright and clear. And not only in front of him, but also in front of his successor ... but he must be very vigilant. It would take great care and considerable effort, and probably many sacrifices, to set her on the right path, but was it possible to achieve true victory without shedding some blood?

Then she came in. He smiled involuntarily, which didn't happen to him very often because he always tried to control himself. Here, however, a slightly more open display of emotions was welcome.

She stood there with one hand leaning on the food cart. Normally, he was supposed to be brought by the servants, but he guessed

that she needed an extra excuse to come here, because it couldn't be that she was here just to see him. Like him, she had some trouble showing her true feelings... and controlling them. The girl wore a red vest and fingerless leather gloves, and her hair, which was tied in a ponytail, was of a dark color inherited from Ashera, stiff and wild like a real Pahtra's, although it grew like a human's. The eyes, although cat-like and multi-colored, had the alertness and intelligence of the Antares family . She stood stiffly, nervous, hiding her uncertainty behind a proud, slightly arrogant posture. She had a hard look in her eyes, one hand on her hip, and a small smile on her face. But the tip of her tail was trembling nervously, and her companion, this strange cat with a translucent mane, was red and blue. He wasn't sure, but probably these colors reflected his emotions. Did they also show what his owner was feeling? At the sight of the unusual animal, Resh stood up, but gestured for it to return to its seat.

„Good morning... Daughter."

The girl's ears twitched nervously, she still probably hadn't fully accepted that he was her Father, but otherwise she maintained her composure. She was brought up well.

„I brought breakfast for Lord Admiral Antares and his companion. "she said in an official tone.

„Companions. Although Lady Sorrowflame separated from us after landing and went to explore Etheria on her own, and Ashurk, my PR specialist, left early in the morning, she is probably still looking for access to the network, but they are my subordinates. But that's not important now. Please sit down. I would like to talk to you, I would like to meet you. „ he pulled a chair for her and she sat down with some hesitation. They started helping themselves to breakfast, each one separately. There were steamed buns with sweet, fruit and bean fillings. Semi-hard-cooked vegetables, cream cheese, smoked fish and coarse grain pancakes. To drink there was sour milk and hibiscus tea. Lady Ka said she would eat later and stayed outside, watching what was happening in the

castle. They ate in silence for some time until he finally broke the silence.”

„It's nice here, definitely nicer than on Atrax, not to mention places like Eox or Aukturn.”

„Where I grew up, in the Fright Zone, nothing was pretty... Well, almost nothing.” she smiled for a moment, but then became serious.

„Yes. Star Siblings told me a bit about your childhood. It's from them that I learned about you.”

This time she looked at him in surprise.

„Do you know Star Siblings? Jewlstar and the rest?” she asked, and he nodded and said

„Yes, they were the first people from the fallen empire I encountered. Very nice, although Starla has a weak head. They joined my fleet.” he said and started spreading cheese on another piece of pie. This news broke the ice a bit, because Catra visibly relaxed, probably without even realizing it. After a few moments she asked.

„How did I end up here if this place was cut off from the galaxy?” there was hunger in her voice, an answer to a question she had probably been wondering about for a long time.

„I don't know the exact answer myself, but I know that Dr. Sidonius, an ancient and extremely lousy vampire, but also a great scientist, was involved in everything.”

„A vampire... A non-dead creature that feeds on blood...„ she said, and when he nodded, she added. “Once, not so long ago, I thought they were creatures from fairy tales that scare children so that they obey and do not rebelled Against superiors.” she said, as if she was referring to some very unpleasant memory. “But where did I come from? We are not alike. We're not even the same species.” she looked at him sharply.

Now I have to be very careful.

“My family... our family has ruled the planet Tarak for centuries, more or less fairly. Not all members of our family were noble rulers like in legends, and there were a few tyrants and even simple fools among us, but overall we were not that bad. When I took over after my tragically deceased father, the situation in our part of the galaxy was extremely complicated. There was a Cold War between the two greatest powers in the region, the freedom and individualism-valuing Pact Worlds and the militaristic, conquest-hungry Veskarium . Both sides avoided direct conflict, instead fighting proxy wars. Tarak has always been on the side of the Pact Worlds, so we naturally became the enemy of Veskarium. So they sent specialists in overthrowing governments, the siblings Igzar and Ashera. They were part of the Pahtra species, warrior and independent catpeople who had been conquered by Veskarium years ago. They were… really good at their job. Taking advantage of old animosities, mistakes of local leaders and sometimes terror, they started an uprising. Igzar commanded the army, but Ashera led the troops and carried out most of the military operations.” he may have been almost entirely truthful in this part of story. After his descendant's reaction, he realized that he was referring to her memories. It's a pity he didn't know her story more thoroughly, because then it would be much easier for him to… win her favor. “Igzar was ruthless and cruel, he did not hesitate to resort to any kind of brutality to achieve his goals. But Ashera was a bit different. I wouldn't say she fought honorably, none of us did. But… she had some scruples. And she was insanely brave, she was not afraid to jump into flames just to get her way, although she was also very cunning and could easily outsmart most of my generals.” he noticed that Catra liked the story he was telling him… Perfect. “We met several times on the battlefield and began to respect each other. At some point we even started corresponding and became very close.” the girl twitched her ears, and her cat raised its head curiously, as if it understood what the story was about. Maybe that's what it was like. He had to remain very vigilant and couldn't underestimate anyone. “I won't lie to you, it wasn't romantic love. Neither I was

interested in her in that way, nor she in anyone else, which is quite common with Pahtra. But... a bond was created between us, a very strong one. However, before the day of the battle that would decide everything, Igzar ordered her to assassinate me. She almost made it." he pointed to the scar on his face and the cybernetic eye. "But I survived, although I lost the war and had to evacuate with my supporters to avoid reprisals from the victors. And Ashera … Igzar did not tolerate failure. He decided that Asherah didn't kill me because of the sentiment she felt for me and ordered her to be killed." Now was the more delicate part, where the truth gave in to necessity. "Igzar committed many war crimes... or maybe he was simply too effective and his former superiors and allies began to fear him... In any case, he was forced to leave the planet. However, he took his sister's body with him... And since he had access to my DNA stored in various places... He took it with him and decided to contact a certain scientist from Atrax, Jantar.... Lady Ka told you about him, I see„ he said when he saw how the girl reacted to the name of the mad scientist. Fortunately, she and Mrs. Ka had agreed on the appropriate version in advance.

„Yes, your companion told me about him. This was the man who created her… and me, right." she asked, and her cat began to look at him suspiciously.

„Yes, he created you in his laboratories. Igzar had large funds at his disposal, which he looted during the war... And which he earned by commanding his company of mercenaries, the famous Shadows of Tarak, so he had no problem paying for the work of the mad scientist-gangster. Igzar came up with the idea that if he created a child that was a combination of his sister and me, it would be able to inherit some of my former influence, as there were still many supporters of my family left on the planet, especially after the new government began to make the planet similar to Veskarium in terms of laws. civic. He hoped that in this way he would take revenge on his former colleagues and return to the big game. But that wasn't his whole plan. He wanted this child to be a murderess, an ideal warrior who would command the Shadows, and perhaps in the distant future go to his species'

home planet to fight the Vesks to liberate his planet. After that, you had one more task. Igzar decided that it would be a very poetic end for me if I died by the hand of my own daughter.„ He poured himself a cup of tea and waited for his descendant to digest what she heard. Catra stared at her hands in disbelief and pain as her pet rubbed against her comfortingly.

„So I was just supposed to be a tool, a weapon created for fighting, right? The sword of Vengeance? But why... Why didn't he take me... and I ended up here... „ she looked down. He sighed and said sadly.

„Because you were a baby and he couldn't wait for you to grow up, so he didn't want to take you. In this case, Jantar wanted to cut his losses and sold you to a research facility owned by the servants of Nyarlathotep , an ancient dark entity, that was run by Doctor Sidonius ... This is where my trail ends”

He looked at her questioningly, and he looked down, and she thought for a long moment, and then she started talking... About her childhood in the Fright Zone, being raised by an evil sorceress called Shadow Weaver, about the difficult life of a cadet. The only thing that allowed her to survive that time was her friendship with Adora . Then her only friend found the sword that gave She-Ra's power, left and joined the Rebellion, and she began her career as a captain of the Horde, and then as the right hand of its leader. The more success she achieved, the more hatred and anger burned in her heart, until finally the terrible incident of the opening of the portal occurred. Then her story was no longer bright and clear, but it all ended with the death of Queen Angela, the mother of the current ruler, and the establishment of contact with the galactic Horde. Then the war escalated more and more, and finally... Here he hesitated for a moment, as if she wasn't sure if she should tell him the truth, but after some thought, she said that Glimmer had unknowingly activated the Heart of Etheria, a terrible weapon created by the First Ones to cleanse the Galaxy. Adora then broke her sword, but Etheria was torn from Despondos and the Horde occupation began almost immediately. His descendant and queen were kidnapped by Horde Prime .

There... Catra watched the Empire's operations closely and eventually found out that Adora was looking for Glimmer, so she helped her free herself, but was punished terribly for it. At this point, Catra fell silent and trembled, reliving the terrible memories. He knew some people had trouble dealing with these types of wounds, so he waited until she was ready. When she calmed down, she said that she was freed by Adora , who had regained She-Ra's power. Her friends convinced her to stay with them. On Kryat she found Melog, who became her companion and then they returned to Etheria, where they continued to fight, but it was difficult because many princesses were Chipped. Shadow Weaver also returned and tried to separate them again. Adora agreed to a terrible sacrifice. The final battle took place when Horde Prime decided to activate the Heart on his own. At first she wanted to leave, but then she changed her mind and forced the Dark Sorceress to take her to Adora. She did it at the last minute, because her friend was fighting a guardian powerful enough to kill She-Ra . They only defeated him thanks to Shadow Weaver sacrificing herself, but Adora was poisoned nonetheless. Regardless, her beloved decided to deactivate the heart, even at the cost of her life. Then she confessed her love and Adora somehow found the strength to survive and unleash the magic. Endowed with full power, She-Ra defeated the Horde and annihilated Horde Prime .... And now they are together.

There was silence. He knew he had just obtained the information he had been sent here for, but he didn't care. He didn't come here to follow the orders of these or other politicians. All that mattered was his goals, and now the future of his house. So he stood up and placed his hand on Catra's shoulder and said the words she wanted to hear.

„I'm proud of you, daughter."

"I'm proud of you, daughter." When she heard these words, a shiver ran through her body and tears came to her eyes, and it was only with a supreme effort of will that she stopped herself

from bursting into tears. Perhaps she should let her emotions flow, as Glimmer and Bow would have advised her to do, but she heard her sister's voice in the back of her mind. *Don't trust him. Everything he says is a lie*. But how much could she believe her? Or him? She felt torn between distrust, or caution as she called it, and her desire for this man to be… He was as he seemed. She really wanted someone who was to her like Mikah was to Glimmer. Who would replace Shadow Weaver in her memories. But she was afraid of disappointment and that the feeling that pricked her soul like a splinter stuck in her finger would turn out to be real. The feeling that everything is too good to be true... Is it really that good?

It was created by a crazy individual no better than Horde Prime... for money. She was created not out of love, but to fulfill her uncle's ambitions. She was a weapon, a blade like a sword of protection…. Like Adora in the hands of Shadow Weaver. For years she had envied her beloved for her uniqueness, at least in the eyes of her "guardian", but now it turned out that she could share her fate.

However, this was not the right time to dwell on the past and its origins. Her father was here and she still had questions for him that needed answers.

„So I was created almost twenty-five years ago. During all this time, hasn't Jantar been trying to create... another person like me? – she asked and looked hard at her father, dismissing all the recent sadness. She had to be strong to find out the truth. The Lord Admiral hesitated and sat slowly in his chair. She felt Melog watching him carefully. The resident of Kryat did not trust this man. He couldn't recognize a lie, especially one hidden among the truth. He had told her that the other man was very composed and concealed his emotions, but now her question unsettled him. It reminded her that she had to stay vigilant and that she couldn't completely trust Antares ...

„Yes, I know of one who survived.„ he said, and she felt her heart begin to pound in her chest and heat spread throughout her body.

„I need to explain to you that our family has a genetic flaw that has made genetic engineering extremely difficult.” she paled when she heard about the genetic defect, because she wanted to have children with Adora one day, but seeing her reaction, the Lord Admiral smiled sadly and said in a reassuring tone. „Don't worry. You didn't inherit it. That's why creating you was so difficult. A few years ago there was a Swarm Attack on the Kes-Atr-On system, where my forces covered the evacuation of civilians from the planet Kesler, and then I fought a victorious battle on the planet Atrax, where Jantar lived. Igzar fought there too, and I would be lying if I said he didn't show great heroism. However, he was primarily interested in the glory that he could use to regain his influence over Tarak. A year earlier, Jantar finally created a teenager that met his standards of perfection. The girl was not only more mature, but also had knowledge about military, leading others and... killing. However, Jantar was too brutal towards his daughters, so they came to me to help overthrow him. I managed to do it, but before Lady Ka gave me your sister, Igzar kidnapped her and, although he died, that girl ended up in the hands of Tarak's shadows. I hadn't heard anything about her until recently, butLady Ka spotted her trail near the zon a few weeks ago, so I put my finger on it. Perhaps I will be able to find her... „ he finished and drank the curdled milk. She crossed her arms over her chest. For a moment she wanted to tell him that she had met her sister. But… She didn't want to take any chances. The girl didn't want their father to be told about their existence, so she figured he would listen to her. If her father was a good man, or at least not a bad one, then he would understand her. And if it is otherwise, it will protect Eti from Admiral Antares.

Out of the corner of her eye, she saw movement in the bushes and what appeared to be a fragment of purple hair. Apparently Entrapta couldn't stand it anymore and went on spying missions to spy on the technology in their guests' possession. Fortunately, the Inventor could move extremely quietly when she wanted to... But she had to not lose control herself before catch the first Gadget that came within the reach of her hair. Normally she wouldn't mind, but the former ruler of Dryl wasn't very good at

keeping secrets. It's time to get ready and take Entrapte with you . But she had to ask one question first.

„ Are there many sorcerers in the universe who practice shadow magic? – she asked carefully, and the Lord Admiral looked at her in surprise, then thought better of it and answered.

„Quite a lot. Although I am not a specialist in the field of mystics, as the most popular type of Magic users is correctly called. This is one of the more common types of dark magic, although that does not mean that its users are evil. From what I know, it is especially popular among the followers of Lao Shu Po, the goddess of deceit, theft and murder, and Zon-Kuthon , the God of Darkness, jealousy and suffering, but also among ordinary thieves or scouts, and other people who rely on hiding in darkness. „ said the Lord Admiral and became lost in thought.

She felt great relief. Although she didn't like all this talk about gods, apparently such practices were much more popular in the galaxy than she expected, but at least there was at least a small chance that it was just a coincidence and her sister didn't end up in the clutches of that bitch. That Shadow Weaver is dead and will never come back. But then Antares added.

„Theoretically it was supposed to be a secret, but we sent a reconnaissance mission first. It was led by Lady Cala Grayskull , who claimed to be a descendant of Mara , who, like your fiancée, was She-Ra, or so she claimed. She was accompanied by her mentor, a woman who had joined her five years ago on a planet called Carurystal, a master of magic, including dark magic, named Miss Daisy."

She felt cold sweat break out on her.

„Was this woman Saihe?" she asked, but seeing the lack of understanding in her father's eyes, she added. "Pointed ears, sharp facial features… And does he have scars?"

Antares looked at her thoughtfully"

„You mean she's an Elf? Yes, she is, although she also has a large admixture of drow blood. As for the scars... I didn't see them on her face, but I allowed myself to gather some information about her employer, so I also learned a lot about her. It is a common fact on Carurystal that she wears a holographic mask to hide the scars and deformities that cover her face. Most believe it's the result of some tragic magical accident and feel sorry for her."

They feel sorry for her. They feel sorry for Shadow Weaver felt like laughing hysterically, but somehow she held it back, even though Melog flattened his ears and emitted the blue of sadness and the yellow of fear. She got up and headed for the exit. She had to think everything over and of course intercept Entrapta before she said something she shouldn't, but her father stopped her by speaking.

„We both know you came here with one question. "Is he a good person," he looked at her carefully.

„Are you a good person?" she asked, answering her father with an equally attentive look.

"No, I'm not." he replied in a polite, dispassionate voice. She nodded and left, much more confused than before.

This planet irritated Lady Ka. It was… pastel… and definitely too nice. Perhaps she had spent a little too much time in the stuffy, filtered air of her transport, but the air here made her feel slightly drunk. Moreover, this place felt like a fucking folk park, or some shitty place in the Galaxy, worse than Carurystal or even Saltmarsh. It was a damn fairytale castle, with a damn fairytale princess, a damn fairytale prince and an equally damn fairytale knight. Only the damn cat was definitely dragged out of her world. She was able to recognize Jantar's work at first glance. She wonder if she also felt that she didn't belong in this place cursed by Devils and Quilpoths

The worst thing was that she felt useless here. The construction of a new intelligence network in the region was going quite well, but here she was cut off from its resources necessary for its work. She wasn't entirely sure why the Lord Admiral had taken her here. At first she thought that her boss didn't trust her and didn't want her to be left alone without supervision, but now she came to the conclusion that it wasn't the case, at least not only that. Antares needed someone he trusted to stand by his side. Although the locals didn't seem too dangerous, on the contrary, they were so pleasant that she felt like vomiting rainbows, but even here someone like the Lord Admiral needed support. Someone to watch his back, keep an eye on everything, and inject him with the damn drug. And of course, someone who would look at everything with a sober eye, that's what he needed most... Sometimes the greatest men and women became soft when it came to the issue of their offspring. She saw it in her boss too, how he softened at the sight of that girl. He needed someone to remind him who he was.

It didn't change the fact that she was bored, so she threw a knife for fun, annoying the strangely dressed guards, and listened to the conversation with the Cat. Her boss told her to install a listening device so he wouldn't have to tell her everything again. The kitten's story was interesting and even quite funny, although the reminder of the fact that Horde Prime liked to chip his clones made her think a little more fondly of that bastard Jantar. She would also like to meet this Shadow Weaver woman so that they can exchange experiences about parenting methods, like cat lady with cat lady. But at the last question, the kitten wasn't sure whether to laugh or gnash her teeth. She didn't like being made an idiot.

And then, almost by accident, she saw movement among the bushes and drew her weapon. She was about to shoot the bastard on the spot when the boss's daughter came out of the house and called.

„Entrapta, please leave… „ and then she looked at her and said sharply. What are you going to do?

Without removing her hand from the gun, she replied in an irritated voice.

„Someone is sneaking into... „ she didn't finish, because the head of a woman with long and surprisingly flowing purple hair appeared from the bushes.

„Hey Catra! I just came here to check out our guests' technology, but quietly so as not to disturb anyone! the purple-haired woman exclaimed.

„One moment and she might shoot you.” she growled and out of the corner of her eye she saw Catra extend her claws and start talking very slowly.

„Entrapta can be curious and a bit... careless sometimes, but she is a friend of me, Adora and the queen, and if anything happened to her, you would have to deal with us.”

The sight of those claws made her shudder involuntarily. However, she refrained from touching the mask. Entrapta waved her hair and said.

„I was in no danger. When we were returning from our last expedition, I set up a portable force field in case something buried me again or we were ambushed..” she looked at her gun, squealed irritably, then jumped up to her and grabbed the gun from her holster.

„”Leave that!” she growled, but the purple-haired girl undressed him in a few moves.

„ This is a fascinating device! Plasma microcapacitor with subgravity magnetic field generator, although it does not have maximum efficiency. If you gave me an hour or two, I could increase the stopping power of this weapon by two hundred percent. There was a time when I would ask you out on a date, but now that I'm married, I don't think I can, although I don't know if Hordak would mind... I know! Let's have a girls' night out! It's basically the same as a date.

” she exclaimed happily. She smiled at the purple-haired woman with the visible part of her mouth. If it were up to her, such people should be thrown into the river with a stone around their necks. Catra gave her a warning look and placed a hand on her friend's shoulder.

“You know Entrapta? Come with me. I need to talk to someone now.

The purple-haired woman nodded, sighed sadly and gave her the weapon, or rather parts of it, back and went with Catra, but as they walked she gave Lady Ka a longing look and a friendly wave. She had to admit that seeing Catra was a strange experience for her. The girl was sexy, there was no doubt about it, but she wouldn't go to bed with her. Not because she was afraid of the Lord Admiral's reaction. Whatever you say about her boss, it didn't bother him when people around him slept together, he was much more irritated by conflicts and excessive competition. No, this was about something else. She looked too much like her sister, the little freak that Jantar had created, and in her opinion such creatures should end at a party with birds.

The Lord Admiral sat at a table and wrote his diary in a self-encrypted journal that he could only read with his cybernetic eye. Of course, it only contained the "correct” version of events. Apparently he wanted to publish it someday. Then he will read them with joy and laugh out loud.

„You told her a beautiful story, boss, congratulations on your imagination.” she said with sincere appreciation.

„Politics is basically telling stories that others want to believe.” replied the Lord Admiral without looking away from his journal.

„So it's almost the same as a scam.„ said Lady Ka, raising one eyebrow.

„Partly, yes. But at the same time, you have to believe in your story, even if you know it's a bunch of nonsense. Sometimes this faith can make lies become truth.” Antares said and looked at her. She considered his words for a moment and then said.

„What will happen when he finally discovers the truth? Because I think we both know that this will happen.”

A Shadow of a smile appeared on the Lord Admiral's face.

„Weave the golden threads of lies into the tapestry of truth so that they become inseparable and impossible to divide one from another. And to put it less poetically, before she knows the whole truth, she must be so closely connected with us that she either doesn't care anymore or will prefer to choose lies. Either way, until then we have to work hard to convince her of... our goals.”

She thought about his words for a moment and asked.

„You don't mind that she's marrying a demigoddess.”

There was a spark of joy in his blue eye.

„What a great choice. It will definitely strengthen our genetic line in the future. I promise that I will be the cutest father-in-law in the galaxy.

She nodded, but she had a feeling that it wouldn't all be that simple, after all, nothing related to gods was like that.

„There is also the matter of the Heart. She claims that this weapon was destroyed. Do you believe her?. she asked, approaching her commander.

Lord Admiral Antares thought for a moment and said in a thoughtful voice.

„Yes, I rather believe her. Anyway, it doesn't matter anyway. These types of artifacts are dangerous and do more harm than good.

Whoever possesses them becomes a target for all reasonable people.”

There was silence again. The Lord Admiral interrupted them, speaking in a solemn voice.

„I wasn't lying when I said I was proud of her. The story she told shows that she was a strong, tough and ruthless leader. If she is properly polished, she will lead her housetowards a golden age and create a true empire. Of course, first we have to remove the obstacle which is Queen Glimmer”

Family Matters part two

Family Matters part two.

Catra was strangely touched by her conversation with her father. Glimmer was never like that, and neither was Bow and Perfuma when they speak to their parents. However, this was a very small study sample. Most of her friends didn't have parents, except for those three, she guess. She herself barely remembered her parents, having lost them when she was just a little older than the Child…. She remembered perfectly her Name Giving Day, which she celebrated with her robotic friends, but they weren't as smart as Emily, they couldn't be her friends. She sent out hundreds of balloons with invitations, but no one came. Only the regency council sent her a card with good wishes and an apology that they couldn't come due to the castle's security system. That day she realized that Castle Crypto was not her home, but a prison. That she was Entrapped there.

„Has something happened to you Entrapta?" Catra asked her, looking at her closely, and Catra's amazing shape-shifting companion brushed against her leg. He must be tested someday, take a DNA sample, do such creatures even have DNA? He needs to ask Catra to ask him about it. Ah, Catra asked her a question…

„I thought about my parents... „ She answered simply, thinking that was enough for her friend, but the friend kept asking.

„Do you know that you never actually talked about them?"

„There's nothing to talk about. They were there and they are no longer there. That's all." she replied to her friend and looked into her datapad. There was data on this strange wolf, she should probably look it up. But she felt Catra's gaze on her and realized that this answer wasn't enough for her, so she looked up from her device and said.

„They're gone, Catra. They left me when I was younger than a Child. I only remember that they said they would go somewhere and they would come back, but they didn't come back... „ She fell silent. Why were they talking about the rhyme? She had so much work to do... Much more important than thinking about... those people.

"I'm so sorry..." Catra said. There was sadness in her voice. She didn't need to mention it. Now Catra is sad. She smiled at Catra.

„ Nothing happened. I built myself much better parents after that. They hugged me every time I pressed a button on the remote control. And they never left me. I have to fix them though. Then I will introduce them Hordak and they will definitely like him. I programmed them to like any of my partner I introduced to them. And I will introduce you to them too! They are supposed to like my friends too... I just don't know about the Child... At that time I wasn't thinking about parenting, but I think I can reprogram them without any problems and the Child will have the best grandparents in the world!”

Catra looked at her painfully. Why? After all, what she told her was so happy, right?

„I promise you that we will look for them someday... After the wedding and when everything would be clear. Do you know where they could have gone?„

Why does Catra keep asking this? It was completely unimportant!

„They went deep into the Mines of Dryll. I guess they wanted to explore the network of tunnels that stretched beneath the mountains. Apparently it is supposed to reach inside Etheria... I think so. Remember those tunnels beneath the City of Elder Things! I think I even told you about the trip I was thinking about. Maybe this isn't such a bad idea! I think my parents left me recordings of their previous expeditions, but I haven't had time to look through them... Do you think your father will let me explore his ship?”

Catra looked at her confused.

„Ship? You've probably seen plenty of them, and most of them don't compare to Darla. Besides, it was probably a very small ship. “ her friend said uncertainly. She tilted her head in surprise. She kept forgetting that others sometimes didn't notice such obvious things.

„But each of these ships was different from the others, or at least from those from other planets. And usually, before the technology of interplanetary travel had developed, Horde Prime arrived and destroyed everything.” she started to explain, but Catra protested

„But Icarus was a trading hub before the Galactic Horde arrived there...”

She waved her hair.

„That's an exception, and besides, it didn't last long. And they... have been developing for hundreds of years without Prime's presence . They didn't even know it existed. Imagine these centuries of uninterrupted development. Exchange of knowledge and thoughts... Peaceful coexistence of thousands of species and civilizations that could share their achievements for mutual prosperity.” she looked into Catra's amazing two-colored eyes, secretly hoping that her friend would understand what she was getting at. However, Catra seemed skeptical. Was it all really so difficult to understand? Maybe she should be more explicit. “They must have technology that we do not know or even imagine.” now understanding appeared on the face of the cat-human, extremely fascinating hybrid. “And besides, there was no heart in the one in other regions of the galaxy, so magic functioned normally there. Who knows what their sorcerers can do. Maybe there are other non-dead creatures living there, like that creature you fought in Mystacor, or Extra Dimensional entities , or maybe even dragons... I've heard a theory that dragons were actually a kind of winged cats. Isn't this fascinating?”

Catra must have not really liked her statement, because her friend turned slightly green.

„The not-dead are not creatures I would want to deal with again. Not to mention some dragons, and besides, in all the drawings they look like fire-breathing winged lizards. What extra-dimensional beings are supposed to be , I don't even want to find out.” Her friend muttered. She was ready to start explaining her theory about the existence of other dimensions and the entities that inhabit them, but Catra motioned for her to let her finish. “I'll try to talk to him… to the Lord Admiral… to my father… But I don't promise he'll agree.”

„Oh, you can tell him that if he's worried about his ship, his friend can accompany me. This Lady Ka will definitely agree to accompany me and will answer all my questions... And I have a LOT of them!” she exclaimed excitedly. Catra looked at her in disbelief.

„Entrapta! This woman wanted to kill you! – her friend exclaimed. She looked at it surprised.

„Many have tried. You too.” She stated, but when her friend flinched, she realized that she must have mentioned something that still hurt her, so she added. “It was just a misunderstanding. I was just sneaking up on her superior for no reason, so I thought I was a ruthless murderer who wanted to kill her superior.”

Catra smiled as she mentioned being a murderer. She didn't understand what was so funny about it. She didn't use violence because it was wrong... But she could create a assassin bot, just by working on it for a while. Such a machine will definitely be useful to them. She was already reaching for Datapad to do a preliminary design, but then her friend said.

„She smiles at you like a snake smiles at a baby bird.”

She frowned.

„Snakes don't smile. They generally have no facial expressions. Unless you're talking about snake people, but that's kind of offensive.”

Catra tried to say something, but then she heard a loud screech in her head.

„She's so pretty!”

Judging by Catra's expression, she heard him too, because she stiffened, and then they heard quick footsteps and a new person was standing next to them. At first she wondered where an ant the size of Catra came from and why she wore a short skirt. And then she understood. It was a real Insectoid. She had heard that Horde Prime extremely hated these types of races and exterminated them as soon as he encountered them, so she must have come from outside the Empire. She definitely came with Catra's dad! She had colorful ribbons attached to her antennae, and she wore a white T-shirt and a short skirt, it still looked strange. She had two legs and two pairs of arms, but the lower arms were smaller, slightly tucked in, and she wore gloves on them. She stood next to Catra, hugged her with one arm, and stretched her out in front of her with the other, holding a very modern-looking datapad .

„Oh, you're cute! Like a little kitten, but a big! Do something kitty-like now!” she squealed in their heads again. Catra stood stiffly, her fists and mouth clenched, and Melog glowed with every color of the rainbow.

„Could you please stop squeaking in my head... By the way, have you heard of such a thing as personal space!” Catra drawled

„Well of course. Don't worry, a cute kitty like you will never invade my personal space!” echoed in their heads again. And then she saw that the insectoid was holding her datapad on a retractable holder, so she could take photos of herself and anyone standing next to her. Fascinating!

„ If you don't let me go soon, I won't be nice anymore and I'll rip your antennae's off." her friend growled and extended her claws. Melog was red with anger. The insectoid girl looked at Catra with what seemed to be resentment, but she quickly backed away from the cat girl.

„By Hylax and Shelyn! Just because you have emotional problems doesn't give you the right to take it out on others! – they felt her irritation in their heads. Catra looked angrily at Shiren with narrowed eyes. She took the opportunity and approached the journalist and started talking into her dictaphone.

„Entry number 38332. Today there was the first contact with a representative of an unknown race of insectoids . She seems friendly." she looked at the still furious Catra. "Although opinions on this subject are divided."

The insectoid looked at her in surprise.

„What do you mean the first one! I am Shiren after all. Don't you have Shirens here !?" She asked her.

„She claims that she is a representative of a species called Shiren and that her species is common in the galaxy."

Shiren looked at her in surprise.

„Common! I am not commonI I have my own channel on Eye of Beholder with three hundred thousand followers. This is not something common." the Insectoid woman huffed. "By the way, my name is Ashurk Klock . I am a very famous influencer and Social Media Advisor to the Lord Admiral." Shiren explained and she ruffled her hair curiously. So many new fascinating concepts!

„ And I'm Princess Entrapta. Ruler of Beast Island and former Lady of Dryl. President of the Creators Guild... And many other titles... And there's my friend Catra and her companion Melog." she pointed at Catra and her friend, who were no longer angry but were just looking at them in amazement.

Ashurk tilted her head to the side in surprise

„Oh, so you use your internet nickname! I'm Strawbery-Ant22. I don't know your websites and social groups, but I'd love to learn about them... as soon as you tell me how to connect to the local network? Because I visited the entire castle, I even woke up the queen, but even she didn't know how to contact her. Maybe you know how to connect to it, because I need to connect and upload my recordings and maybe contact my followers, and also update the Lord Admiral's profile on the Book of Faces because I haven't done it for several weeks. There was no Internet on Taurus, because there was a war, although in my opinion the war is not a reason not to take care of your network life and health, but Etheria is supposedly a very nice and peaceful place, so there should be access to the network with good bandwidth, right? In my home, on Atrax, access to social media is considered one of the basic rights of thinking beings, much more important than, for example, education or access to clean air."

Entrapta stared at Ashurk with pure delight. For the first time in her life, she completely did not understand what the other person was talking about. It was a strange feeling, a little unnerving, and at the same time she felt like she was having an epiphany. This is how others feel when they talk to her?

„Network? Yes, I'm trying to create something like that here on Etheria , but everyone associates it too much with Horde Prime . You have something like this on Atrax, right? Will you tell me about it?" she asked, rubbing her hands and hair."

„Oh, the Infonet is the most wonderful place in the Galaxy. Billions of beings meet there and... well, they do a thing!" the insectoid girl explained to her .

„What things? "she asked, feeling uncontrollable interest.

„Well, various things... Important things! For example, watch photos of furry, cuddly animals and food... „ replied Shiren. She had no idea what she was talking about, but it was definitely

technical jargon with some fascinating ideas hidden behind it. He just needs to listen carefully to the insectoid and I will find out everything.

„I guess I'll go now... „ said Catra, looking at them uncertainly. "Since you two get along so well…" and she walked away, leaving her with her amazing new friend.

The last time she had such a bad wake-up was when she first woke up on Velvet Glove, alone and abandoned, at the mercy of a mad tyrant... Okay. Then, when she woke up on Eridani with a fever of almost forty degrees and snotty because she didn't realize it was winter there, it was also bad, but she was completely unprepared for something like that. The guard woke her up with a call that someone from the Lord Admiral had come to see her on extremely important business, and she jumped to her feet. Then an ant in a mini skirt ran into her bedroom and started screaming at her that she needed her help. Screaming in her head, let's add. It almost stopped hurting her. She asked the ant what happened and it started screaming again, still in its head, that there was no connection to the local network. Without it, her fans have no contact with her…. She frowned. It didn't sound like anything really important, certainly not important enough to wake her up after three hours of sleep. She wanted to yell at her, but Bow politely told her that her problem would be solved soon, and for now she should eat breakfast. The ant nodded and left. However, further sleep was out of the question, so she first dealt with her morning sickness, which she had been having a lot lately, and then she went to eat breakfast herself, and then went to her Torture Chamber, i.e. the royal office. She had no idea how her mother had stayed there for so long. Especially when there was a war, she had to deal with it, and dad... was missing. Now she finally understood how hard it was for her mother sometimes... Her mother was alive. She still couldn't get used to the thought. It was similar to the fact that her dad survived. When the war finally ended, for several months she always remained silent when he entered the room where she was staying. Even Catra found it

easier to talk to him then, though maybe she should have told Catra especially. Sometimes she envied her friend's relationship with her dad. Although they eventually managed to form a bond, it was never as… simple and direct as the one created by Cat Girl.

And now her mother was alive, but she had become as alien as possible. Her evening certainty that everything would somehow work out was gone, leaving behind the dark specter of fear and worry. What if she doesn't remember it? And will he never remember? Will she ever become what she once was? It's like she died a second time. Or worse yet, she remembers everything but doesn't care? What if she had changed so much that all that was left was hatred, without any love. She heard her father's stories about the Light Spinner . She was, according to her father, a wise and noble, although demanding teacher. Some of her former friends and colleagues spoke similarly about her... She had sometimes seen these traits in her when she taught her sorcery during those few months of the final period of the war. But Catra and Adora only knew her as a monster who did everything to ruin their lives. If Light Spinner could become Shadow Weaver, then her Mother, Queen Angela, could become Captain Moonshadow…

Shadow Weaver is alive. It was so… Unfair. The woman who had taken her father away, who had imprisoned and tortured her, who had feed the worst in her, was alive and probably well, while her mother, for all her sacrifice, was punished with suffering and contempt. She had often heard people from Eridani and the smaller continent of Icarus called Dedalus talk about the mercy and graciousness of the so-called gods. If there really were beings so powerful in the universe, why did they let him suffer such a fate?

She realized that she was reading the document for the fifth time, completely not understanding what it said. She sighed and yawned. She once signed documents without reading them, which resulted in her giving the entire mountain to some scammer from Ikarus. Then she looked at HighMinister Shou. Otter person usually helped her with the paperwork, but today she was especially distracted, even jittery. She was hardworking and very

empathetic, and she think it was the latter quality that made Shou feel so bad. The previous night had been harrowing for all of them, and Sou felt what each of them had experienced. She knew how difficult it was to watch her friends suffer, so she understood the High Minister well. And the specter of war still hung over them, so the woman who wanted peace suffered twice as much. Fortunately, it looked like they could avoid the worst, although now it was all up to Catra. “Trust her. In these five years, she hasn't given you the slightest reason to suspect her of anything. She's your goddamn friend.” she said to herself. The problem was that she didn't trust her father at all. Fortunately, Catra shared this view… So much good.

She sighed, wiped her temples and said to the minister with a friendly smile.

„I guess that's it for today, neither of us can focus on work, so I guess we need to rest and sort it all out. I'm going to the training room.” she said and tried to teleport. This time she succeeded and she screamed happily as she entered the Training Room.

The training was surprisingly pleasant, it relaxed her a lot, and the return of her teleportation skills greatly improved her mood. After half an hour, Adora came in. They looked at each other surprised. It was probably the first time since they had known each other that she was here before the warrior. For a moment she tried to check in with her friend to find out how she and her fiancée were feeling, and finally she asked.

„How... How Catra feels?” She asked carefully, but Adora smiled warmly, so she felt extremely relieved, and then the warrior added.

„She didn't really want to get up, but she didn't seem as scared as I thought she would be.”

„So she's with him now.” she said quietly, but she had the impression that her words echoed ominously throughout the room. They were silent because there was nothing to add. Now

everything was in Catra's hands. What happened to all of them depended on her. All they could do now was wait patiently.

The training room was built for them by Entrapta, using some of the equipment from the Fright Zone, as well as holographic projectors brought from Ikarus. It was a completely new quality of training for her and Bow, although Catra was used to most of the exercises available here, but Adora Well, nothing could replace the training sessions Light Hope provided her, although they had no idea how many secrets the ancient AI was hiding from them.. However, without her, Adora couldn't train She-Ra's powers... Not without the risk of blowing the entire training room to pieces... In the future, they planned to make three similar training rooms. One for the Eherian soldiers, one for the sorcerers of Mystacor , and a third for all the princesses, so that together they could develop their powers now strengthened by the annihilation of the Heart of Etheria . But it was a song of the future, which now appeared in increasingly darker colors...

Suddenly Brother Blade marched in. He was very upset that he had been tricked by Catra's sister and she managed to escape. The Grand Marshal didn't blame him for it, but the clone was very concerned about his failure.

„Queen Glimmer! A woman wants to see you immediately. Judging by his appearance, he's not from the Empire!„ The clone shouted. She sighed and said.

„Enter them... „ she said and thought. *Will this procession of newcomers never end?*

They decided to welcome their guest to the Training Room since he insisted on meeting her immediately. They didn't wait long for her. After a few minutes, the guards, led by the clone, ushered in the tall woman. She was approximately forty years old. She had long golden hair and a scar on her face caused by some caustic substance. Still, she was quite attractive. She was clad in

ominous-looking plate armor that clanged loudly with every step. She had a strange sword attached to her belt, completely incongruous with the outfit she wore. She actually looked friendly enough, if it weren't for those eyes. He affects many of the inhabitants of Etheria, as well as some people from planets conquered by Prime . It was the mark of war burned away by decades of war, often a lifetime spent fighting. Only while in others it glowed like stars in the sky, here it burned like the sun she had seen on other planets... although wasn't the sun just a star seen up close? In any case, she would definitely be able to take down all the guards and only Brother Blade would put up any resistance. She and Adora would obviously be able to handle her...She guess.

The woman stood in front of them and knelt on one knee.

„I am Asindesa di Vir, Lady of Blades of the Order of Eclipse, Hell Knight." she shouted loudly. Newcomer. Most of the terms meant nothing to her, but she had heard about Hell from the people of Eridani. It was supposed to be a legendary land full of monsters or something like that.

„We are pleased to see you, Asindesa di Vir, Lady of Blades." she wasn't sure how she should address the newcomer. "What brings you to us?

The woman stood up and spoke in a slightly softer voice.

„I was on leave and wanted to rest in this place after the hardships of the fight, but I heard rumors that someone from the Research and Exploration Fleet had arrived here, so I decided that I should also introduce myself to your majesty."

She sighed and said in a tired voice.

„Call me Glimmer, or if you prefer to call me, just call me queen. We on Etheria are not that formal in our everyday lives. „ She pointed to Adora , who was looking at the knight with a strange expression on her face. "This is Adora She-Ra, Princess of Power.

In fact, Lord Admiral Antares , commander of the Research and Exploration Fleet, came here. I understand he is your superior?”

Hearing her words, the woman grimaced.

„I follow the orders of the Lord Admiral, because I and my soldiers have been delegated to the fleet, but my only superior is the Lictor of my order.”

"Everything is starting to get more and more complicated," she thought, feeling more and more tired and depressed, and then added.

„I will order the servants to prepare a room for you in the castle.” she ordered in a quiet voice, but the woman shook her head and said.

„There is no need. I will stop at one of the local temples. We usually do this on our personal hikes”.

I think we have one Glimmer thought, and Asindesa continued.

„ I would just like to ask for the freedom to roam around your castle, Queen Glimmer.

She hesitated. She wasn't entirely sure if that was a good idea, but she nodded and said.

„You will be notified accordingly, but I would like you and the Lord Admiral to come to dinner this evening.” she only just came up with this idea, but it seemed quite good.

Asindesa nodded and was about to leave when Adora asked in a serious voice.

„Where did you get this sword?”

Asindesa hesitated for a moment before answering.

„A great warrior gave it to me just before he passed away.”

She felt a little guilty about leaving Entrapta with that annoying mind-talking ant, but she guess that Lady Dryl and she liked their company, so she probably shouldn't worry. For her, hearing a strange voice in her head was a terrible experience. Too similar to what she felt when she was chipped by Horde Prime. She preferred to limit being around this person as much as possible, especially since he was extremely irritating. She used to get mad at Scorpia when he invaded her personal space, but she's become a bit more patient since then, and Scorpia has learned that not everyone likes being hugged. This girl was pushy and treated her like she was a pet which was so annoying! She was one hell of a Grand Marshal, and she earned that title. Some idiot squeaking in others heads won't treat her as if she were an element of decoration... With which to take pictures.

As she was thinking, she heard Castaspelia's voice .

„Oh! Catra! It's wonderful to have you here.”

She turned around and saw the Chief Sorceress. She seemed surprisingly tired. Well, organizing a royal wedding was tiring for anyone, and here she was also taking care of her and Adora's wedding. She couldn't forget about that fight in the library either. She managed to cope with it somehow, but not everyone had to be as tough as her and as resistant to the horror lurking in the dark corners of the world. Her mind was forged in the fire of suffering and fear... After all, she was a child of the Fright Zone and a "ward of the Shadow Weaver". Standing next to the Chief Sorcerer was Nightgale . Given that she carried a notebook with her, she probably became Castaspeli's assistant . Whatever she thought about this woman, she was definitely helping Aunt Casta with organizational matters

„Hello, Castaspella!. How are wedding preparations going?„ She asked, smiling friendly. The Chief Sorcerer beamed, even though she was exhausted,

„Oh, this will be a wonderful event. We'll make holograms projecting the four of you and Melog in the sky ! And guess what! We will organize a real Masquerade Ball!

What! was all she thought. The lack of a masquerade ball and Masks in general was one of the few wishes she had for her own wedding. She guessed that even though Casta didn't like her, she probably didn't do it maliciously, just out of distraction, but she still felt a burning anger. Seeing the smile disappear from her face, she felt dejected.

„Wait, this wasn't supposed to be a Masquerade Ball, right? Oh, somehow I'm trying to cancel everything. I'm sure I can do it if I hurry.” said the Head Sorceress Princess with panic in her voice. She touched the bridge of her nose with her fingers and told her in a tired voice.

„It doesn't matter anyway. Now you have to figure out how to entertain my father and his entourage.”

„Your father?!” Castapela asked in shock. Nevertheless, Nightgale was amazed . It even surprised her. In a few words she explained to her what had happened.

Then she smelled it. He was very weak, she even felt like she was imagining him... But he was incredibly repulsive. She was used to terrible smells. Just living in the Fright Zone made her immune to the stench, not even counting the toilet cleaning she was often tasked with as part of Shadow Weaver's punishment. But this was something completely different. Unnaturally terrible… She turned and saw two women. One of them was Klementine , a small and sad girl with purple hair and sharp, deep green eyes, the daughter of General Jocelyn . She knew her, but not very well. Supposedly, she spent her childhood with the General's ex-wife somewhere in the Dryl Mountains, but that woman died during the occupation, so the girl lived in Brightmoon. Their relationship was complicated, to say the least. Her mother lost part of her power to the Grand Marshal, but she probably didn't blame anyone for it, because she preferred to take care of her daughter. She wasn't entirely sure,

but it seemed to her that Klementine had a distaste for both her and Glimmer, which she could understand. She had the right to blame them for the death of one of her mothers. But the other woman was unknown to her, although she immediately guessed who she was. She was beautiful and tall, blonde, with wonderful long hair. She was beautiful, but something made the hairs that grew along her spine stand on end. She was the source of that smell.

„Good morning You must be that famous Grand Marshal Catra. Very nice to meet you. I am Lady Cala Grayskull of Carurystal, descendant of Mara , which I guess makes me sort of your future wife's closest relative…" she held out her hand, smiling at her even though her eyes were cold.

Nightgale, despite her amazing discoveries, could not return to Castle Crypto and think things through as Scarlet, because she had to remain in her role as the assistant to the chief sorceress, although being in this body was not as tiring, unlike working for Castaspelia. Well, that woman had a right to feel distracted. After all, it's not every day you see someone come back from the dead. She only wished she knew anything about what they were talking about, but it was only a matter of time before she found out everything. She just needs to be patient. However, she managed to gain a new, wonderful ally whose help will be invaluable...

„Something happened here... Something unusual. Can you feel it?" she heard Aaravos' voice coming from the small millipede in her ear. Giving Castaspelia the document that would allow her to take the mirror to her room was child's play. The Head Sorceress was so distracted that she didn't pay attention to what she was signing. Performing the ritual was much more difficult. The wound she had inflicted on herself to split the blood was still throbbing with pain. But it was a sacrifice worth making. Thanks to this, at this moment, this strange Saihe could walk alongside her through the halls of Brightmoon Castle .

She had to agree with him. Something happened here. She felt it in the behavior of the guards keeping the castle safe. At first she thought maybe one of the brothers had attacked, or maybe Lonnie had carried out some action that she hadn't bothered to tell her about. Then she came to the conclusion that it was because of Frosta's dethronement , which must have shocked everyone present. Castaspella paced around her room for a good fifteen minutes and muttered to herself, probably convinced that Shadow Weaver was responsible for everything. The truth was much more mundane. She felt sorry for Frosta, but there was little she could do about what happened to her... The Ice Princess was one of the few people who showed kindness to her despite learning the truth about her...

They then came across Catra. Of course, the Grand Marshal didn't even suspect who she was dealing with, but why would she suspect the Head Sorcerer's assistant of anything? She felt like, for a brief moment, telling her about her mother's, or rather their mother's, recent visit, but of course she couldn't and wasn't sure she really wanted to. Aaravos regarded the feline girl with surprising interest, though he clearly wasn't going to tell her why, and she couldn't ask without arousing suspicion. However, during what they expected was an ordinary conversation, it turned out that Catra had found out yesterday that she had a father, which was only surprising, but that father was from outside Etheri and came from outside Etheri. For a moment she wondered if he was the person Foretold by the Creeping Chaos, but the Great Outer God would hardly forget to mention his emissary's connection, but then again, who could fathom Nyarlathotep's motives? However, she had to quickly let Lonnie know that there had been a complete shift in the balance of power on the planet. But before she thought about the next steps she should take, but then she felt It!

It was power. Strange and Wonderful. Powerful and Terrible, beyond anything she had ever encountered, except perhaps that one burst of power when Horde Prime was annihilated. She turned and looked at her, at Cala Grayskull , a demigoddess who walks among mortals. Perfection Incarnate.

Song of the Void

Chapter Summary

> In the meantime, as I write the next chapter, I'll give you this poem.

See the soul of light in the void
What stretches between the stars
Which illuminates the darkness of despair and fear
Devouring even the bravest
Hearts

The Power of the Sword and the Stone
Trials of love and suffering
A clear path leading to
Divinity

In your dreams you see
Your future among the stars
I prophesy to you eternal glory
In the midst of the infinite
Loneliness.

Hear the soul of Hunger resounding in the silence
There's a scream in the middle of it
Which pierces the self through and through
Those who want to feel at least once
Peace.

Fury of annihilation and destruction
The sins of pride and greed
The winding road leads towards
I will lose it

In your nightmares you hear
The snapping of a thousand thousand maws
I'm warning you against war

Which has no beginning nor
End

Feel the soul of emptiness
That stretches between the stars
Where ancient knowledge lies
Which understanding may cost you
Soul.

A song of horror and madness.
The power of friendship and courage
The last star brings
Hope

In your heart you discover
Truths that were buried
They will be the key to
Wins

He who can lie for ages is not dead.
He who has no one to live for is not alive
Even death can die with strange ages
Even the wicked can find peace
When they finds love in his heart

Return to Castle Crypto

Chapter Notes

This chapter took me a long time to write. As always, please leave your comments and opinions

He felt happy to be coming home. Although he wasn't entirely sure if Castle Crypto could be called that, but he had nothing else that resembled him. At least he will rest in warmth after the hardships of this expedition. He had to admit that it was the most difficult adventure of his life. And what's worse, it's not over yet.

He looked at the sword hanging at his side. He didn't have a decent sheath for him, but he knew they'd have no problem getting one for him once he got back to the castle... Though he wasn't entirely sure he'd want that. All the way there he considered throwing away his sword. It would be so easy. It would be enough to throw it into the depths of the ocean while they were sailing on the ship or give it to one of the inhabitants of the settlement where they were staying, but he couldn't bring himself to do that. This sword was the first truly valuable gift he had received in his life, apart from the love of Lonnie and Rogelio , of course . And what would Messrs. Lance and George think if they found out he just threw it away like garbage? But it was actually about something else.

That little moment when he became that big guy was wonderful. He felt strong and wonderful, practically invincible. For as long as he could remember, he felt like a failure. The one who always lets everyone down and is never good at anything. No matter how hard he tried, he knew he would never be as good as Lonnie and Rogelio. They cared about him and didn't make him feel that he was in any way inferior to them, but he knew it. He could only

hope that they would never get hurt because of him. But now he had a sword. A real magic sword that gives him power! If he could control it, he would become a great, mighty warrior, as powerful as Adora... Like She-Ra...

And that was what made him now live in constant fear. He couldn't say it out loud or even formulate it in his mind, because the truth was too terrible. But in the end he had to accept her, even though she terrified him. He was someone like Adora, one of the First Ones, perhaps even a relative of his old friend. He didn't know much about this ancient race, except that they had built many amazing devices, including the Heart of Etheri, which almost killed them all... And now they turned out to be his race... He didn't know what to make of that fact. He had always thought of himself as an ordinary boy, quite weak and clumsy, but just like Lonnie, Rogelio, or even Scarlet... though maybe the latter wasn't the best example... He looked nothing like Adora, apart from the color of his hair, of course. He admired her and even had a crush on her for a while… Until he realized that she and Catra were into each other…. Which was noticed by absolutely everyone except them two... Why would he be someone like her. He remembered how betrayed everyone felt when she became She-Ra and then defected to the Rebellion. When it turned out that she was one of the First Ones, he was practically not offended, unlike Lonnie. His girlfriend found herself personally hurt by having to compete with someone who had an unfair advantage over her from the beginning. In her opinion, both Catra and Adora had always been Shadow Weaver's protégés, though he didn't understand how being the object of the dark sorcerer's attention could help anyone. He couldn't imagine what would happen if Lonnie found out the truth about him. She would probably exile him, or even try to kill him, Like Catra wanted to do to Adora. He doesn't want to wander around the galaxy alone, even with this wonderful sword, or fight against his friends. But there was another possibility, maybe even worse. What if Lonnie wants to use his power in her war against Catra. She would definitely want him to do terrible things, and he didn't like hurting others, even though he did it

during the war. But with this much power he could spread death and destruction… No, there's no way Lonnie can’t will find out.

The trip back was surprisingly quick, or maybe it was just their imagination? He wasn't sure. All the way, he, Rogelio, and the Imp remained silent and sullen... Though the Imp had always been silent, but now he was clearly sullen. Everyone was worried about Lonnie. The wound of the Comrade General looked really bad, and the chariot that Scarlet had summoned didn't inspire the least bit of trust... But he Scarlet didn't trust either... Even before he knew the truth about her, he didn't like her, and now that he found out who she was... Although he wasn't really sure what she was. Maybe she was one of those monstrous doppelgangers who stole people's identities by devouring their brains. Shadow Weaver liked to tell them stories about these monsters serving the princesses, and so they would report to her about all the strange behavior of the inhabitants of the Fright Zone. Until now, he thought it was just another of the Dark Sorcerer's stories. But now he was starting to believe in her. If that monster had devoured Scarlet during the war... That would explain everything... Why she was so different from the cadet who they remeber, why she suddenly learned magic... Was Lonnie to be her next victim? Probably not, because then she would have to give up Pretending to be Scarlet. Unless he took her to another monster, and together they would devour their girl and another creature would take the place of the Comrade General... But that thought was too terrible to contemplate.

But this creature looked so familiar. There was something too familiar about her... She looked a bit like one of the clones, but she also had a lot of Shadow Weaver in her. Was she their child? If so, how they made it… He didn't want to imagine it. While he understood that clones could be quite attractive, the Dark Sorceress was the scariest and most horrible person he knew. Compared to her, even Scarlet didn't seem that bad... In fact, if you think about it, she wasn't that terrible... Compared to Shadow Weaver, almost no one was terrible... It's a good thing she was so dead.

Rogelio sensed that something was wrong with him and invited him to the tent several times, but each time he refused, claiming that he was not in the mood, which was actually true. He couldn't make love to him while hiding such terrible truths... Dr. Moors, on the other hand, didn't shut up at all. He talked almost constantly about the ship he and his allies had found. He had to admit that the ship looked like something truly amazing, but he had absolutely no idea what they could do with this. They were a People's Rebellion, not space pirates. None of them would even know how to fly it, let alone get it out of the ice, though... He had a strange feeling that Doctor Moors didn't care much about it, as if he already knew how to free this ship. It even seemed to him that there was some kind of agreement between Lonnie and the eerie scientist, which weighed heavily on his girlfriend... Even Scarlet, who probably suspected something, was disgusted, although she didn't tell anyone. Another reason to worry.

When they reached the coast, Octavia was already waiting for them, and she did not hide her joy at the absence of the Comrade General. He didn't like it very much and they glared at each other the whole way back. I mean, he, Rogelio and Imp watched, and Dr. Moors thought aloud about their last trip. He also seemed oddly interested in Catra. He asked them about his former friend quite intrusively, and they tried to give him the most perfunctory answers possible. They had no idea why the brain in cylinder was interested in their feline friend, even though they were now on opposite sides of the barricade.

Once they disembarked, they headed towards Castle Crypto . On the way, they stopped at a settlement called Rush Valley. The residents were loyal to Lonnie and welcomed them with what they had, although everyone tried to keep a healthy distance from Dr. Moors, but the children were delighted with the Im . There they learned about Frosta's dethronement ... At that moment he felt like a traitor and a bastard. Frosta, together with her rather terrifying friend, saved their lives in the underground, and now she has lost her throne. He was sure it wasn't the Comrade General doing. It wasn't like her to plot and intrigue, let alone have time to do it. However, he was sure that they were

responsible for removing the ice princess from power. He felt bad about it. However, they did not receive any news about Lonnie's health, and they preferred not to ask too much, so as not to reveal too much of what happened there, in the ruins of that damned city...

In the morning they continued their journey and arrived near a landing pad that had been built here some time before they took over Castle Crypto and All Dryll. Since then, very few people have used it, because they had no ships of their own, and others were afraid to come, although they did not cause any problems for those who wanted to go there. Once they were visited by a nice Eridian who gave him a pendant that was supposed to belong to Shelynia or something like that. He didn't quite understand what he meant, but he kept it because it was pretty... Now it turned out that there was a quite large ship here. He couldn't recognize where it came from, even though he didn't know much about spaceships. After a short discussion, they decided not to sneak past the ship, but to remain vigilant.

As they got closer, they saw that most of the crew were young people, not much younger than him, who were looking around. There were also two elderly Saihe women, one dark-skinned and silver-haired, the other with green hair and terribly gloomy, who wore sorcerers' robes. Although he had never heard of sorcerers living outside Etheria, he knew very little about other planets in general. There was also a clone dressed in colorful clothes, quite an unusual sight in an area controlled by the Rebellion. Lonnie wasn't oppressing the clones, but she was letting everyone know that they weren't welcome here. Small reconnaissance drones spotted them first, but not until they got closer. Then a cheerfully smiling girl approached them and started waving her hands at them, and a voice began to come from her gloves.

„Hi! I'm Rossie. Very nice to meet you. We are looking for a way to Castle Crypto. We would like to stay there for some time.”

The girl looked friendly. He once had a deaf friend named Kate. She was one of the cadets, but she couldn't hear the orders, so

she was sent to the technical department, where apparently a nice family adopted her, and for Scorpia's wedding, she made a mural of a young couple. Actually, she was lucky. She escaped training from Shadow Weaver. Why had he been thinking so much about the cursed sorceress lately? It's probably because of Nightgale.

„Of course, but now it's the headquarters of the People's Rebellion and we are in conflict with the queen, so you know.” he replied, smiling equally friendly. Her companions turned to him. Most of them didn't look that friendly, especially the short but muscular redhead girl with the large axe. He noticed that as soon as he spoke, the sullen Saihe stood up, and for a moment he felt as if he knew her from somewhere, because the way she moved seemed disturbingly familiar, but then he heard a voice behind him.

„Hey Blond Boy, Are you accepting new members to your Rebellion? Because there is a VERY serious conflict between me and the Hag Queen, and you will need such an absolutely perfect, awesome person.”

Frightened, he jumped and screamed, then turned around and was speechless. Catra was standing in front of him! How on earth did she find him here! And so fast. He was about to apologize to her, but then the girl said in a slightly irritated tone.

„Yes, I know, I'm a lot like her. For Daemons and Asuras. Does everyone on this damn planet really need to know her? Damn celebrity.” the girl snorted and now he realized that it was not Catra. At least not completely. They were very similar. He didn't have time to think about it, because then he heard the voice he had heard so often in his nightmares.

„Kyle was your sister's friend, just like Rogelio. They were nice kids. But what are you doing near Castle Crypto? And above all, what is this People's Rebellion all about?” Shadow Weaver said in a surprisingly gentle voice. He started to tremble. Rogelio drew one of those strange weapons given to them by Migu. He tried to

find his weapon, but he was so terrified that he couldn't remember where he had hidden it. He considered reaching for his sword, but that would probably make things even worse. The others also drew their weapons. The tattooed Saihe summoned a translucent blue blade out of nowhere, the redhead grabbed her axe, and the Silverscale Lizard drew his blaster. The white-haired woman looked at him in surprise, but then took a fighting stance. Why did they want to fight for Shadow Weaver. As he struggled to draw his weapon, the cat-like girl placed a heavy metal hand on his shoulder.

„Don't be afraid, Blond Boye. It's not undead, just good old Grim, alive as always. Although, actually, I don't know if she's alive at all.” she said and started rubbing her chin with her leather-gloved hand, as if she was thinking.

"Good old... Shadow Weaver," he tried to understand who could possibly think of such a combination of words, and then he saw the symbols of the First Ones on his hand and felt himself fall helplessly against the stone.

Eti looked at Blond Boy, who suddenly fainted. With a loud growl, Vesk ran up to the boy and hugged him tenderly, like a best friend, or even someone more. "Alatar would probably like to hold Itel in his arms one day," she thought, somewhat unconsciously. She hadn't slept since yesterday, and during that time she broke into the castle, was imprisoned by the Hag Queen for no reason, and made a daring escape... And she met her. Yes, it was the longest day of her life. And it wasn't over yet, They had to get to this castle as quickly as possible. Not out of fear of the queen. Despite her obvious problems with controlling emotions and aggression, she doubted that she wanted to hurt them. But if she tells her father where they are hiding, then... He will want to get them and hurt them... they have to hide, and Grimmy claimed that this was the only really safe place. After all, Grim knew this planet better than all of them.

It was Grimmy's planet ... Actually, she should have been angry at her for not telling them the truth, but... She didn't feel angry. The Dark Mystic could have saved them a lot of worry, especially Itel, but then again she probably wouldn't have accompanied them and it would have been much harder for them to hide now. They could no doubt need someone who knew this planet right now.

Moreover, she also knew her sister... She even raised her. That was why she was so interested in her, and not because she liked young girls like Itel claimed... She probably didn't know her sister's parentage and she was shocked to learn that the Lord Admiral was their father. But there was something else here... The way she described her relationship with her sister... there was something else hidden there... An understatement, as if she wanted to put something very important into words, but made them understand that she hadn't told them everything yet. She just wasn't sure whether she was motivated by fear of what they would do when they know the truth, or whether she had some dark plans for them. However, she was sure of one thing. Whatever her intentions were towards them, they could not be worse than what Lord Admiral Anteres wanted to do to them.

Sparkle Paw smiled at Vesk again, and lowered her hands, then said.

„Will you let me see your friend? I think he just fainted... from the impression, but I think I should watch it. I have first aid training."

However, when she approached him, the lizard backed away from the white-haired girl and growled at her menacingly.

„I'll try his language.„ interjected and translated what Sparkle Paw said, but Vesk only widened his eyes in surprise.

„ Wrgagh?!" He growled in a confused tone.

„ his Vesk doesn't seem to speak Vesk. Alatar said with surprise, and Grim nodded and said.

„The local Vesks, like most elves, do not speak their native language, but Mr. Rogelio, due to... a congenital condition, does not speak at all.”

Then she saw a black metal cylinder moving towards the dark mystic, moving on long metal tentacles with grippers at the end. It was a very spooky Droid.

„Interesting, I expected the dragons to be bigger, although it may be only an apparent similarity, after all, evolutionary convergence is a very common phenomenon in the universe.” he said in a strangely metallic voice, and Alatar looked at him scowling at the suggestion that he was a small dragon. But the strange Droid didn't pay any attention to him and just approached Grimmy.

„Ah, so we finally meet. I heard rumors... But you survived...„ he said, staring at her with eyes attached to the tentacles.

„I survived... You can put it that way. And who do I have the pleasure of talking to?” Gloomy replied to him in an extremely serious voice, and the shadows around her deepened ominously.

„True, I forgot that the last time we saw each other, I looked a bit different.” he laughed so ghastly that even her hairs stood on end. “Mi-Go can be really good friends.„ he spread his tentacles wide, but seemed alert. She had the impression that there was a relationship between him and Grimmy. A small winged creature sat on a nearby escarpment. For a moment she thought it was Imp, one of the smallest, but also the meanest, devils, but he looked slightly different, completely unlike these fiends. He actually looked like a Wrongdak child , did they ever have children?

„If someone's dream is to have their brain locked in a can, Mi-go can truly be considered the greatest friends. Oh, I know who the fungi from Yugoth are, I've learned a lot in the meantime.„ The Grim woman smiled contemptuously and continued. “However, this is not the time for malice and verbal quarrels. Important things are happening, much more important than our previous

conflict, and if either of us makes a mistake, the price will be terrible.”

Grimmy can be quite melodramatic sometimes, she thought and went to Blond Boy, who was just waking up, and said.

„ Listen, Blondie. I don't know how you lived with Grimmy , but for me she's fine. Save your fear for our Father, I mean my father and Catra's, because he's a bigger son of a bitch than anyone you've ever seen. Come on, don't faint again, okay?”

Lonnie returned to work as soon as she was well enough to speak, although pain shot through her face with every word she spoke. However, she did not want to let anyone know how much she was suffering. She knew it was a habit from the Fright Zone, instilled in her by Shadow Weaver. The Dark Sorceress did not tolerate weakness. Even though she had been dead for years, her spirit lived within them. I wonder if she would be proud of herself?

Returning to work was a strange experience. In her absence, everything, the entire Rebellion, functioned without problems… as if she was completely unnecessary… She should feel proud, because it showed that the Rebellion, her Rebellion… Their Rebellion would survive if she was gone, but it made her feel mortal. For the first time in her life she realized her mortality. That the world would continue when she was gone and all memory of her would pass away... Then she felt an overwhelming longing for Kyle, Rogelio, Imp and even Scarlet. The Sorceress had to leave her because of her cover as Castaspela's assistant. She felt so alone then.

Shortly after waking up, Scarlet reported to her about her negotiations with the Chancellor, one of the Star Sisters, and someone who was apparently Shadow Weaver's sister... She was initially angry at her deputy for conducting the talks on her behalf, but had to reluctantly admit that they had gone terribly wrong.

well, and their result was probably the overthrow of Frostas, which was probably the greatest success of the Rebellion, to which none of them had a hand, probably the first such case in history. However, she had to admit that their trip to this strange city turned out to be extremely fruitful. Not only did they get the device they came there for, but they also found proof, very tangible proof, that what the Overseer said was true, which, however, did not fill her with joy. This meant that she would have to keep her contract. She will have to give the innocent woman to the monsters so that they will condemn her to a fate worse than death.

It was already after noon when Grizoll came to her , even more grumpy than usual.

„Kyle and Rogelio are back.” he said sarcastically. She felt the warmth of relief spread through her heart.

„That's great!” she screamed and smiled regardless of the pain that shot through her body, but Grizoll looked at her gloomily.

„Great? We'll see what you say when you see who they brought with them.” he said and motioned for her to follow him. When they reached the courtyard, she saw that all the rebel members who did not have activities that did not allow for a break were standing in a not very neat line. It was nice that everyone came to greet her boys... But why was everyone so tense, so alert, as if they were ready to fight. What's happening here?

She saw Kyle, Rogelio and the imp. She was relieved to see that they were all right, although Kyle looked strangely pale. Dr. Moors also looked safe and sound, though she wasn't sure that statement was appropriate for someone who was a brain in a metal can. The first person she saw was a clone, judging by the painfully colorful outfit it was a local clone from Etheria. Have they caught a spy? That's probably a good thing... In addition to them, there were several young people here, the age they were when Catra took over, and two slightly older Saihe women. The young people were armed and looked fierce, and the women wore

Sorcerer costumes. If Kyle and Rogelio recruited them, they did a great job. But why was everyone so…scared? Something was wrong.

„ Hey Scar! You know the recipe for this stew, because it's great!” she heard a voice coming from the side. She turned around and saw Catra eating stew straight from the pot where one of her subordinates was cooking dinner over a fire.

Catra... Ate... Stew... In Her Castle.

„What are you doing here!„ she exclaimed in disbelief, and Catra walked up to her and said.

„I'm eating stew You do not see? Do you have vision problems? You should eat more carrots. It's supposedly good for your eyesight. There's a lot of carrots here. Eat that!” she put the spoon into her mouth. Now she realized it wasn't Catra. Different voice, eye color, hair color... But who the hell was she!

„What the fuck does that mean!” she exclaimed, and the girl looked at her resentfully.

„So this is how hospitality looks like here. I say right away that I will not give away the food.” she walked away from her and started looking menacingly through narrowed eyes.

„Miss Eti hasn't eaten anything warm for a long time, and from what I've noticed, she gets extremely grumpy when she's hungry.”

Her heart stopped at the sound of that voice. However, she overcame her fear and looked at the Saihe woman, who spoke to her.

Shadow Weaver. she just whispered, and Hordak's former right-hand man nodded and approached her. She tightly gripped the metal staff Mi-Go gave her, ready to desperately fight for her life, but the dark sorceress simply said.

„You've gone high, Lonnie. I underestimated you, even though I have done so with many people... But this is not the time to dwell on past mistakes, for Etheria is surrounded by dark powers and we must stand against them together. But first... „ and then the Dark Sorceress, Lady of Darkness, Hordak's second in command the woman they had been afraid of like nothing else in the world for almost their entire lives, knelt down on one knee in front of her and said in a serious but also humble voice. „I would like to ask Comrade General Lonnie for shelter for me and my wards. I stand behind them with my head and swear that we will obey all the laws and orders established by you and will not do anything that would endanger you or your subordinates."

She stared at Shadow Weaver for a few moments, speechless, completely unsure of what she should do. This woman has never had an ounce of humility in her. She was the embodiment of arrogance, just like Catra. She was only able to humble herself before Hordak, and only because she was afraid of him. *Will I be the new Hordak now if I accept her?* she thought, but... Shadow Weaver was kneeling in front of her... Wasn't this the greatest success she had ever had?

„Agreed, I accept you. But don't try any tricks. I now have allies that even you could never dream of." she said, trying to sound as authoritative as possible,

"You mean Mi"Go. You won't see such creatures even in my dreams... Not in my dreams. With such allies, there is no need for enemies." Shadow Weaver said in a strangely sad voice.

Something Wicked This Way Comes

Chapter Notes

I'm not sure if I understood correctly how the spell concealing the facts about Aravos works. I invite you to comment and provide your opinion

Lady Sorrowflame smiled as she looked at the walls of the library hidden in the Whispering Forest... This planet was a very interesting place. Full of power that penetrates her deeply. She wondered if her inhabitants were aware of this. Probably not. They had been used to it since birth… perhaps… She wasn't entirely sure. When she arrived on this planet with the Lord Admiral and the rest of his entourage, they stayed in the town of Brightmoon . For the capital of the planet it was small. Even smaller than many of the cities of the Lost Golarion, such as Egorian, the capital of the devil-worshipping empire , Nantambu , the damned city of magicians who so often spoiled her plans, and finally Absalom, the city where mortals could became gods. Where the Starstone was originally located... Well, the Starstone... The mere fact that this planet was home to the second copy of the most powerful artifact in the Galaxy made it worth visiting. It was a discovery far more significant than anything she had made in the past centuries, all of her service to the Lord Admiral's family. It was a tool to gain power beyond all imagination. With it, she would be able to pass the Starstone Test and Ascendance on her own. With this, the Truth of Dahak would return in her. New goddess w, beautiful in her terribleness.

However, as she discovered, there is still a lot of work to be done. Once in town, she looked for a place where she could learn something, so she went to a local café, a place where second-class intellectuals or those who wanted to be considered intellectuals gathered. Such places have existed on every planet in every era, and they have always been abuzz with gossip. As soon

as she entered there, she attracted the eyes of many women and men, her human body was very attractive, it often made tasks like this easier for her. She greeted everyone politely and sat alone at the table, ordering a surprisingly ordinary coffee, although of course to her everything tasted of bitter ash, apart from, of course, the one and only liquid that was more delicious than ambrosia. Even now she craved the red nectar. In new times, a substitute was created that satisfied her needs, but not her hunger. She was already used to this constant hunger, and with a huge effort of will she managed to keep it in check, but there on Taurus she could finally be satisfied, although only for a moment, because then the thirst hit with a vengeance, so when two deer women invited her to her table, she couldn't take her eyes off the veins in their necks, where the life-giving substance pulsed. They must have misunderstood her interest because they both blushed, only fueling her desire. After the usual exchange of pleasantries, she introduced herself as Lord Antares' chief engineer, a minor understatement that was necessary on this peaceful planet whose inhabitants would be reluctant to hear about the wonders of dark technology. She tried not to reveal too much about the identity of her superior, although they would probably find out in the morning anyway, if the Admiral went well in his meeting with the queen, which she had no doubt about, because Antares was an experienced politician who was not afraid of any young monarch.

Both women were a couple. Their names were Red Leaf and Blue Grass and they worked at a university located in the nearby mountains, a town as large as the capital, with a very original name: University. She carefully questioned them about Etheria's treasures and the legends that circulated throughout the planet. Then they realized that their interlocutor was not from here, which only increased their interest. They immediately decided that the greatest treasure of their planet was the sword of protection found by Adora , which gave her the power to transform into She-Ra . She had heard about this woman from the Star Siblings. She was supposedly the fiancée of the Lord Admiral's daughter and a heroine of the galaxy, and according to the Horde Ultimate, the Lady of Chaos. She was also said to be one of the Firsts, the last

of this ancient race. That explained a lot, but she was skeptical about both the girl's origins and whether she was the last one. In her opinion, this is not what a descendant of the race that created the Anacites, a race of mechanical beings from Abbalon, should look like, but then again, who would have guessed that she was a dragon? However, she left her thoughts to herself.

The sword, however, was destroyed when the Heart of Etheria was activated She had heard something about a heart on Taurus, mostly from the clones. They claimed it was a terrifying weapon that he wanted to possess to cleanse the universe, but then they lost contact with Him. She was unable to find out more, even despite Lady. Ka's enhanced interrogation techniques and her medical treatments. Now the women told her that it was a terrible weapon using the planet's magic created by the First Ones. The Queen accidentally activated it the first time during the war, and the second time it was activated by Horde Prime, but Adora destroyed it and then obliterated Horde Prime. This explained who was behind the attack on the Pact Worlds, Veskarium and the rest of the galaxy, although such an explanation was surprisingly disappointing, but then again, it wasn't the real reason they had come here... The Lord Admiral had probably already found out everything about the whole matter even such unimportant scholars knew. Such a weapon... Such power... It was easy to guess that it was related to the Starstone, and that the locals were completely unaware of how it really worked, or that there was this ancient artifact on their planet. It was all almost funny, once again the ignorance of some turned out to be a blessing for others. Finally, she asked if they knew where to start looking for information about the history of this planet. For a moment, the two women discussed where she should go. Most of the history of Magic and Mysticism was stored at the largest and only magical college on the planet, but she could also go to their town to the University or visit the Royal Library. Eventually, they decided that the best place to find information about Etheria's past was the Forest Library, which belonged to the techmaster's Bow parents, Lance and George. After receiving instructions on how to get there, she agreed to go with the women to their shared room,

which they had rented for the Victory Day celebrations. She satisfied their hunger there, although in different way than what they expected... However, she did not kill them, she was able to control herself enough, but for the next few days they will be very weakened and, of course, they will not remember anything about their meeting.

She had virtually unlimited resources, but well, she succumbed to her primal dragon nature and convinced the ferryman to transport her near the library using vampire hypnosis so as not to have to get rid of the valuable coins. Then she set off on foot towards the library...

She couldn't remember the last time she was in a real forest. She spent her last years mainly working in her workshop aboard the heavy cruiser Invincible or conducting research in her laboratory located on the same ship. Even when she served the Lord Admiral on his home planet, she very rarely left her research complex where she worked during the war, until Asera blew it up with an atomic bomb... Now she was in a true pristine forest emanating life energy, pure energy of vitality. She sensed his will, powerful and ancient. He heard whispers, though she didn't understand them. But she didn't have to understand them to know what they were whispering about. This Forest hated her, wanted to destroy her. As a red dragon and former priestess of Dahak, she embodied the destructive nature of flame, turning all living things into ashes to fertilize the earth. This Forest was still able to understand, because it was part of the cycle of life. He accepted it, even though he was afraid. But as an Undead, vampire feeding on life energy, she was an abomination, a denial of the natural order of the world. She defiled this pristine forest with her very presence. She was like a worm gnawing at the fleshy flesh of the Whispering Forest self. He wanted to destroy her so badly, and at the same time she felt that he was afraid of her.. Whatever he did, whatever power he used, whatever monster he sent against her, it would all be for naught. She was too powerful and he knew it. Maybe if all this She-Ra helped him... That would be interesting... Unlike her commander, she had no illusions that sooner or later she would

have to face the Hero of the Galaxy. The only question was who would emerge victorious from this clash.

She knocked on the door, and then another. After a few moments, she rang the bell, and only then did she hear a noise from inside. The door was opened by a dark-skinned man with a mustache and a heart on his shirt.

“I'm George. Co-curator of this library with my husband Lance. How can I serve you?”

She smiled, trying not to show her too long fangs, and bowed courtly.

“I am Lady Sorrowflame from far away Tarak” She hesitated, wondering how much truth she could tell him, but she decided that this time she would take the risk and tell more truth... “I am the Chef Technician of Lord Admiral Antares, commander of the Research and Exploration Fleets and father of Lady Antares, whom you know as Grand Marshal Catra.” she said, admiring how the man's eyes widened in surprise. – I would like to ask for the opportunity to use your wonderful Library.

“Catra's father… Our Catra…. Adora's fiancée?”

“No one else. Lady Catra is his heiress and successor.” she said in a patient voice. She knew the topic would immediately turn to the cat girl. She was curious how she reacted to this news. She regretted a bit that she wouldn't see it.

“Lance! You won't believe what I tell you!” the man called into the house

Despite the evening time, the library hosts welcomed her very friendly. They served tea and snacks and invited us to the table. She refused snacks, but willingly drank tea, because despite her nature, she was able to enjoy the aroma of tea infusion, even if to a limited extent. George's husband, Lance, had his clothes in

disarray, and judging by his some confusion, she probably interrupted them with something a little more intimate. However, the news she delivered to them made them forget about everything else.

“So Catra has parents! It's amazing. I mean, there's nothing really surprising about it. After all, everyone... Almost everyone had some parents, but we never thought we would meet her father!... Everyone was sure she was an orphan from the Frightr Zone. She raised them... Adora and Catra, that Horrible Woman. Her name was Shadow Weaver. It was the Lady of Shadows... We only met her once, at Glimmer's coronation, but we all got chills when we saw her, didn't we, George?” Lance said in an excited voice.

George nodded seriously.

“She was the right hand of Hordak, the ruler of the local Horde. She was Saihe ... A human-like creature, but with pointed ears, she nodded and interrupted him.

“We call them Elves. They are quite common in the Pact Worlds, especially on Castroval ...” she said and remembered a certain dark Elven sorceress who accompanied Lady Cali. This was surprising news, but on the other hand it explained why the young Aristocrat had joined this expedition. But that wasn't her problem. She came here for a completely different purpose. “Sorry to interrupt, but I think it would be best if you learned the whole story first hand, from the Grand Marshal and her father. I came here for a completely different matter. I am a scientist who has gained a lot of knowledge in many fields... I am older than I look. One of my areas of interest is history, and I have learned that you are the most brilliant historians on the planet. You also have the greatest library in the Etheria and I would like to use it to figure out the past of this place.

Lance's eyes sparkled with interest .

“My family has gathered here knowledge from the last thousand years of our planet's history, if not even earlier.” he said and

pointed invitingly at the countless shelves behind him.

“You haven't experienced the Gap” she asked with genuine surprise. Both men looked at her not understanding what she was talking about, confirming her suspicions.

“So no...” she said thoughtfully and then began to explain. “Three hundred and seventeen years ago, all the inhabitants of the Galaxy woke up and found that they did not remember anything. They knew who they were and who the people around them were, they knew basic facts about the world around them, but that was all. They did not know their past or the history of the universe. All historical sources turned out to be impossible to read. In short, several thousand years were lost, and so far little has been recovered.” Lance and George looked at her with a terror that was completely understandable in people who had spent their entire lives researching the past and suddenly learned that all the knowledge they had acquired could be lost in an instant, without cause and irretrievably. “More than three hundred years have passed since then and most beings have been born into a new reality. Just some, the most long-lived ones, like the elves we talked about recently or dragons, for example...” she stopped to pour herself some tea when Lance stood up and shouted.

"Ha! I knew dragons existed after all! Are there many of them living in the Galaxy?!"

She smiled mysteriously and said.

“More than you could expect.”

There was a moment of silence, after which she asked one more important question, so important for a person in her... existential state, it was extremely important.

“I have one more request for you. I suffer from an extremely rare genetic disease and certain forms of radiation emitted by certain celestial bodies are deadly to me. Such radiation is emitted by the

moons you know as Nir, Cel and Eli. I have a device here that shows me their sunrises and sunsets.” she showed a watch with the option of tracking the movement of celestial bodies, a device very popular among Vampires and other creatures that do not tolerate sunlight, although it is also very often used by shapeshifters such as werewolves. The map of the heavens was obtained courtesy of the AI that controls arrivals to this planet. “That's why I would like to ask you for some shelter, a small room or at least a small room sheltered from the light of those moons.” She said and looked closely at the faces of both men. Unfortunately, vampires were very common throughout the galaxy and most of its inhabitants knew well how to deal with similar creatures. Of course, there were very few beings in the universe that would pose a threat to her, and certainly they weren’t not the librarian couple, but it was better to be cautious. For a moment, she had the impression that a shadow of suspicion crossed their faces, but the mention of the genetic disease prevailed. It's amazing how people were afraid of offending disabled people.

“Of course! We will provide you with appropriate shelter.” said George, and she smiled with the satisfaction of a wolf let into the house by unsuspecting kids.

She had to admit that she was already weaned from working in the old style, without the help of computers. She took with her a datapad and some other electronic equipment, mainly decryption devices and a scanner, but she had to use analog methods of searching for books. It was tiring and time-consuming, but she had to accept it because she needed the resources of this place. Luckily, Lance and George were ridiculously accommodating and kept the place tidy, although she was amused to note that there were many books with quite controversial content hidden in various places. For example, they put the Book of Dead Names under the leg of the Marble Table. She effortlessly lifted the table and pulled out a book. She looked through the issue, although she didn't pay much attention to it, as the Great Old Ones were not in her area of interest. She read a few accounts of Etheria's history, but they didn't contain much information about true antiquity, just dull ruminations on events that were of interest only to the

inhabitants of the planet. On the other hand, she found a brand new and very interesting textbook covering recent history, from the arrival of the Horde to the defeat of Horde Prime by She-Ra. She scanned it especially for the Lord Admiral, so that he could read about the achievements of his Daughter and her fiancée. Unlike Lady Ka, she had no dislike for the cat girl. She wasn't worried about her position after the Lord Admiral's death, and even if she was, she would find a job anywhere with her skills. She clung to the Lord Admiral out of comfort and habit rather than out of true devotion. They both knew it perfectly well.

At some point she came across a scroll. It was ancient, made of paper magically protected from destruction. There she saw an elf who, at first glance, looked as if he had some devil's blood, because he had horns, but overall he looked quite strange. The text was clearly written in Dragon, which she didn't expect from this planet based on Lance's recent statement . However, as soon as she started reading it, the text blurred. She smiled when she saw these safeguards and cast Dispel ... And she was blinded by the power of the spell hiding this text. As soon as she regained her sight, she realized that it was something incredibly valuable. She then tried to use a true seeing spell, but this time her eyes began to bleed. She thought for a moment, then looked around to make sure she was alone. She then transformed her eyes into dragon eyes. Then she looked at the text and smiled and said that she could read the scroll. His text was.

Aaravos is one of the Firstborn, touched by the stars of Draksaihe , a star elf as he calls himself, one of the greatest creations of the First Ones, called the Great Ones in his homeland. Great is his wisdom and terrible is his power. He does not live in any of the kingdoms of Etheria, he does not serve any princess. He lives neither in the ocean nor in the depths of the earth, but in Xadia, a distant world beyond our prison. Yes! Sethis's Tricolored theories are true about the fact that we are just one of a thousand thousand worlds floating in a sea of stars. Many of them were visited by the First Ones, not just Etheria. One of these worlds was Xadia . It was there, mixing the blood of terrible monsters called dragons with the blood of relatives our Saihe, they created

Draksaihe . The star-touched Draksaihe were leaders wielding great and terrible power. They were powerful beyond imagination. In addition to these, they created the merciless murderers of the Moonshadow Draksaihe, the fearless warriors called the Sunfire Draksaihe , and other types, each created to fulfill a different role in their great empire. However, one day, contact with Eternia was severed and the Xadia colony was left abandoned by the rest of the First Ones who were looking for a home. During this time, Aaravos was perfecting his power, but the descendants of those from whose blood he was created, jealous of his power, imprisoned him. But although deprived of freedom, he is not completely powerless because he left behind mirrors, thanks to which it is possible to contact him even after his imprisonment. Unfortunately, the only mirror I know of was taken from us and hidden in… here the entry ended. On the other side there was a portrait of a strange Elf. He smiled friendly, but in his eyes, perhaps completely unconsciously, the artist portrayed a wicked cunning. *A planet full of Dragon-Elf hybrids? This might be interesting*, she thought, smiling much less friendly than the Elf on drawing.

The Lost Queen

Chapter Notes

As always, please leave your comments and opinions

“I don't like what our captain is doing.” Second Officer Gydwa snapped, and boatswain Kaert rolled his eyes.

“You never like what our Captain does. When we won the pile of gold, you also complained...” They will stand in front of Veska and he added. “We both know that you are more concerned about her successes than her failures, because you dream of her chair. I respect that, but it doesn't mean I'll side with you for no apparent reason.

They were in the ship's canteen. Theoretically, Free Captains could not forbid their crew members from discussing whatever they liked, including complaining about the captain, but the practice was such that many of them were eager to suppress any signs of dissatisfaction, usually very brutally and preferably in person. Their captain, however, was not a paranoid person sniffing out conspiracies everywhere, which was her great advantage. He also knew that Gydwa would be much less understanding in her place. That's why he steadfastly stood by them and the Captain, even if she had been acting quite strange lately.

“She attacked that girl and dragged us into a fight with her allies... and ours too. They damn near killed us! Is this what normal people do?!” Gydwa growled, glaring at him with her one eye.

“We are Pirates. This excludes normality. I remember bad old Krush Purpleeye. When his team lost the match, he first shot their coach, and then kidnapped members of the opposing team and cut off their left leg and right arm. And he was killed by Sin-Ko, who was a fan of the opposing team. And this was only the beginning of the Great Steelball War. What Moonshadow did is still

within the norm. The girl took the sword from her and did not want to give it back. She even brazenly lied that about not having that blade, although she summoned him right afterwards...” he didn't finish because Gydwa interrupted him.

“And then she almost destroyed our ship! What the fuck possessed her to attack the fucking demi-goddess and hero of the Galaxy!” Veska drawled. It was realy strange indeed. He never thought he would witness a sword fight with a cruiser. And actually a winning one. He was a simple pirate, if there was such a thing. He didn't sign up to fight someone who looked and acted just like Iomadae's avatar.

“It was a mistake, I admit. But our captain didn't know about it either. Maybe our captain didn't know the true power of this sword, or didn't know that the girl was capable of wielding it. There are countless possible answers.” Boatswain explained carefully. Veska snorted.

“The Captain better start giving them to us, and for now we found out that she is a fucking queen, although even she seemed surprised by it.” Veska said, clenching her fists angrily. Kaert shrugged.

“She wasn't the first to take up piracy after losing the throne, and she won't be the last. Famous Lord Antares has commanded the Fearless Armada for over twenty years. And he probably still believes that he will regain his throne. Our captain probably believes this too. However, this works to our advantage. If she could get her back... As her crew, we would be rich beyond imagination.”

Second Officer Gydwa looked at him skeptically.

“First she had her stupid war with the Azlanti. This made us a mortal enemy to the most powerful empire known, because she had to take revenge. Just because I'm a Vesk doesn't mean I have anything against the Star Empire. Let them talk nonsense about human supremacy and oppress non-humans. I don’t care! Okay,

we made some money on them, gained some fame and contacts, but at what risk? But okay, I can digest it. But now she has plunged us into her old conflict over the crown. With a kingdom that defeated Horde Prime , a Tyrant who left a trail of dead planets in his wake and ruled for millennia... What chance do you think we have against someone like that? With the most powerful country in this part of the galaxy."

Kaert leaned back in his chair and folded his fingers into a pyramid.

"This might be a bit of a problem, I admit. However, no one becomes a pirate expecting a simple, safe life. We expect to face dangers that would make ordinary people shit their pants. I don't know about you, my dear Gydwa, but I am aware of what a dangerous profession I have chosen. The truth is that most of us will die in combat or end up behind bars or thrown out of an airlock. We agree to this because it is a wonderful, exciting life that will be filled with deeds that are both glorious and wicked. We will rise above the gray crowd of ordinary bread eaters. And if we die in the process... fiend's blood! We will all die someday, but we have a chance get a prize that ordinary yeast paste eaters can only dream of. And the greatest reward of all awaits us, the crew of the terrible Merciless, commanded by Captain Moonshadow. Think, my dear Gydwa. Our captain is no ordinary pirate, we always knew that. Certainly the current rulers of Etheria have enemies. If we play the situation properly, we can overthrow the queen and take power... We are a bunch of bastards, hardened in battles with the Azlanti , who are not afraid of anything. And don't forget about Reh-zar and his wonderful ship. If thanks to him we get our captain the sword that gave the power that that girl used, we regain her throne, we take control of the second Starstone and we are in possession of this ship, then it is certain that Moonshadow will become the Queen of the Free Captains."

Gydewa responded with mocking laughter.

"We don't even know if Reh-zar will be able to repair his ship..."

Then Kaert smiled broadly, because he knew something that his companion did not.

"Reh'zar reached the ship . He managed to get this ship going. In a few weeks he will arrive here with his ship. It's a Colossus-class ship. It's called Bloodstone."

This insult requires blood. A lot of blood. The whole bathtub... No, the pool. Yes, the whole pool. And he will drain their blood through a straw. As thin as from a juice box, thought First Officer Tonado as he stomped furiously on the Captain's Bridge. His wonderfully wonderful captain sat in her chair reading the repair reports. For several days now, since meeting that wicked, lying sword wench. Not only did she rob her, but she also lied straight out! But at least she admitted that the captain was a queen. True enough, she was already a queen to him, great and powerful, but now it turned out that she was a royal queen. His little, but great Skittemander heart beat faster. He mentally swore to himself that he would be willing to sacrifice his life to overthrow this odious usurper and regain his captain throne.

There was also the matter of that treacherous Aristocrat and her vile entourage. As soon as the Captain returned to the ship she was hurt, scared and confused. She didn't tell anyone who she was fighting, but there was no doubt that they were overwhelmingly outnumbered, probably two hundred to one. And they had tanks and combat robots. Nothing else would have made her run away. But this army had to be led by this Lady Cala, and she was helped by this cat lady. The blonde girl with the weed in her hair must have been behind this ambush. Already at the first glance he noticed that she was evil because of her cruelty and veganism! It was clearly visible that she was Azlanti. If it weren't for her disgusting weeds, he would have cut her into pieces. A small cube, from which he later made bigos! Yeah it is. And he will add her weed to the pot.

After the fight, Captain did not speak to anyone and did not explain anything to anyone. Some of the crew didn't like it. He heard many of them muttering angrily, especially Gydwa. He knew he should keep an eye on her, or even both. He just had to keep an eye on the captain, and he couldn't get them out of his head yet... He'll have to learn that eventually.

“Reh-zar will arrive soon with his ship.” Captain Moonshadow finally broke the silence. Skittermander felt a pang of regret in his heart. Reh-zar was his captain's partner, as well as his previous first mate. However, he stayed in the place where they found this wreck, which they found out about thanks to the same Azlantean ship that had a map with the location of this damned Etheria. No, not damned it was the kingdom of his wonderful Lady Captain, it couldn’t be damned, it simply had lost its rightful ruler. The Azlanti had begun the process of repairing this wreck, so Reh-zar only had to supervise the entire process.

“That's a great news!” he exclaimed, trying to sound as happy as possible. He saw that his Captain's eyes smiled and she stroked his head with her live hand.

“My brave Tonado. Sometimes I wonder what I would do without your passionate heart. You don't have to worry about your position. Reh-zar will command Bloodstone, you will remain my first officer. My right hand.”

He looked down and said with guilt in his voice.

“I'm not worried about ceasing to be First Officer, I'm just worried about not being with you, my lady! I will never abandon you!”

In fact, Captain Moonshadow was the first person to show him true kindness. When he was still a half-witted Skittermander cub, he accidentally boarded a freighter. The captain treated him like a stowaway and forced him to work off the debt, which, however, kept growing because the captain added food and accommodation to it. He worked there for several years, mainly as a cleaner, with no hope of freedom. Eventually, the ship fell victim to pirates who

took the Skittermander aboard. Not much has changed for Tonado. He still had to work as a deckhand, all he received was basic combat training. It turned out that he had talent, although he had no way to use it. However, one day they came across Captain Moonshadow, who saw how they treated him. After what the Azlanti did to her, she hated slavery, so she demanded that the captain free him. When he refused, she killed him and took the Skittermander aboard. From that moment on, he swore that he would serve her as long as he had breath left in his chest.

"Your faithfulness is one of the few certainties in this terrible world. Now I'm going to talk to Tirin. Keep an eye on everything, my brave first officer." she said, and then moved to the navigator's room. As he watched her go, Tonato once again vowed that he would get this She- Ra and cut her to pieces!

Tirin stared at maps of the region, calculating drift coordinates. The local maps and star atlases they had obtained before they had to leave Ikarus were accurate, and she learned a lot from them, but they were completely unsuitable for Drift travel, so she had to enter all the data manually. It didn't bother her. After all, she was good at navigation and always liked to be useful. Of course, no one on this ship had ever made her understand that she was useless, that she was a failure, unlike at the camp, although she was never sure how much of that was due to Moonshadow. The captain of the pirate ship had always been kind to her, even back then in the camp. She had no reason to do so. After all, she was one of the ones who hurt her. She was Azlanti.

Sensors detected Captain Moonshadow's approach, so she stood up and opened the door to let her in. She always moved slowly and carefully, although her fragile, crippled body was hidden in bionic armor, so it was in no danger. Captain Moonshadow stood in the doorway, smiling at her under his mask. She always smiled when she saw her, even in the camp when she was suffering so much. Once they were free, she told her that she reminded her of her daughter. If any of the guards had heard this while the

captain was in captivity, she would have been severely punished. After all, Tirin was a pure-blooded Azlanti, even if so miserable, and Moonshadow was only an non-human prisoner, albeit a slightly more valuable one. The navigator did not know who the captain's daughter was, except that the pirate loved her very much. Moonshadow herself didn't remember her, neither her face nor her name. Just her laugh and her hair color. So much had been taken from her… She tried her best to replace her, just as the Captain was replacing her mother she never knew.

"How are you feeling, my dear?" asked the captain, sitting in the chair. She took off her mask because here, in the Navigation Room, which was also Tirin's cabin, the oxygen content and pressure were also increased. The navigator's lungs were even more damaged than Moonshadow's, and even numerous cybernetic changes did not help her much. One day she might replace her lungs with completely artificial ones, but as long as she was in the armor, and she usually didn't leave it for days, it was fine. Without this armor she felt helpless, and to be honest, she was helpless.

"I feel good, Captain." she replied in a quiet, hoarse voice. She smiled, even though her face was obscured by the breathing apparatus. The captain stroked her dark purple curls tenderly.

"It's a pity that we stayed on Ikarus for such a short time. Maybe if we stayed there longer, you could come out and look around the place. It was really nice there." there was sadness in the pirate's voice. The thought of going out into the open, under the open sky on a planet she didn't know, made her shudder. She didn't like leaving the ship, and the open spaces on the planets terrified her. She preferred the vastness of space a hundred times more, at least it was pure, untainted by what it had distorted her body.

"I've been looking at the maps and I think it would be best if we looked at a place called Wherever. Supposedly, those who were escaping from Prime's watchful eye once hid there, but now it is a free and open port. It doesn't say Wherever that there were pirates there, but I guess that goes without saying." she said,

trying to change the subject. Captain Moonshadow listened to her and nodded.

“This might be a good place, we'll learn the language there, the crew will have some fun and the mood will improve. It'll be all right.” said the pirate. There was silence for a moment, until finally Tirin asked.

“What actually happened there? In Clytemnestra.”

Captain Moonshadow thought for a few minutes. She seemed to be deep in thought, or perhaps in memories. She didn't remember much, but sometimes new memories of the life she had lost forever came back to her. Maybe not? She was not the life of the party and found it very difficult to overcome her overwhelming shyness. But she was a good listener and she learned something about what happened there in the city.

“I have no idea. For a very long time I thought about this moment, I longed for it, even dreamed about this moment. Until finally my dreams came true... Everything happened completely differently than it was supposed to. This girl... She was completely different than I expected. She should have been a vile, vile traitor, someone who would run away in terror or beg on her knees for mercy, but she wanted to give in, like someone who has been tormented by past mistakes for many years. But the first moment she saw me, her eyes lit up with pure joy. Tears ran down her face... Those who betray their friends are not happy to see them. Nor do they risk their lives against a warship to save the city's inhabitants. I'm only sure of one thing. My name is Angela... It even fits, don't you think?”

Wherever had been a hidden place for decades. Partly because those who ran the place were reluctant to share the secret of its location, and not everyone who came here was allowed to fly away. However, the truth was that the most important factor that saved this place from annihilation at the hands of Horde Prime

was the fact that those who stayed here posed no real threat. True rebels usually stuck to conquered planets, trying to stay close to the center of power in order to wage their unequal fight against an empire that stretched across the known universe. They usually died in the end without achieving anything significant, forever forgotten by history. However, the inhabitants of Wherever chose a different path. They just wanted to hide and somehow survive in the empire by feeding on its waste. It did not bring them glory, but it ensured safety and allowed them to enjoy a semblance of freedom that other inhabitants of the Empire had not even dreamed of. However, when She-Ra destroyed Horde Prime, a real sea of new possibilities opened up for those who lived here. There weren't many deep space ports in the Empire, and almost all of them existed solely to serve the needs of the Navy and the clones that served there. Wherever was that one exception. It may not have been the great interstellar port of the pre-Horde stories, but it could be a place for trade and needs that the clones had never dreamed of, at least until the fall of their Big Brother. There were bars and inns where crews could relax from the hardships of space travel. A marketplace where you could buy goods from all corners of the former empire, and even a few brothels and casinos for those looking for more thrills.

The station's authority had changed, but not completely, and relative order was still maintained with an iron fist. This helped in trade, after all, without any law it was impossible to trust partners and conduct business. At the same time, Wherever remained completely independent of the revived planetary governments. Everyone could come here without fear of being prosecuted for crimes committed on one of the Planets. Traders and famous cyberneticists from Icarus came here. There were also visitors from Aquarius selling strange devices, as well as visitors from Eridani selling potions. Sometimes even Horde Ultimate's subjects came here, although they preferred not to flaunt their origins. There were even inhabitants of the legendary Etheri ahere a few times, bringing with them incredible stories about magic and sorcery.

Skrad was a Goblan from Aquarius. And he was proud of it, although being a representative of his not very tall people required strength of character, but he never lacked it. He spent most of his life operating wells and trading water, surprisingly dangerous activities on his home planet. When Horde Prime was annihilated, a new source of income appeared. Alcohol, previously banned throughout the Empire, became widely available. Skrad has always been interested in brewing drinks, although so far they were only herbal infusions, and after the liberation it turned out that he had a real talent in this field. When a representative of his clan became ambassador to Etheria, the clan council decided to send him here to use his unique skills. He made his money selling a liqueur made from bitter Gresh berries and bought a bar from Iron Bone, the former owner, who decided to return to Icarus. Soon after, he met Hares, a beautiful deerwoman from Etheria and former apprentice of Mystacor . Thanks to her, he learned about magic, in many different senses. He smiled to himself as he cleaned the glasses, because he was planning something special for today. He made a traditional crown from flowers that was given as an engagement gift. Today he would discover new forms of magic, he was sure of it.

Suddenly, a large and menacing-looking group entered the bar. They were dressed in purple clothes and carried weapons and armor of excellent quality. Among them was a strange multi-handed creature with a pirate hat, a slyly smiling Saihe , and a tall lizardman that looked like Waste of Etheria. However, what attracted the most attention was a tall woman with a crystal mask covering the lower half of her face. She looked intimidating. She had an aura of authority around her worthy of true authority. He had no idea where they came from, but he was sure it wasn't any place he had heard of.

As the tall woman approached him, he sighed. This day was looking quite good.

Captain Moonshadow had had a constant, pounding headache ever since she met that girl. She felt as if her whole world, everything she took for granted, had collapsed again. She was once again that lonely lost woman who woke up in the hospital. This time, however, she had no intention of letting anyone hurt her. She wasn't helpless this time. Former Captain Moonshadow, commander of the terrible Merciless, Scourge on Azlanti!

But she was also Angela, and even Queen Angela. Reh-zar often suggested that she might have been of high birth because she had manners and a way of speaking befitting a true lady. She always laughed off these words, because if she were someone important, someone would try to find her instead of leaving her in the hands of Azlanti... Although, if she came from Etheria ... The locals had no idea about the existence of the Star Empire, they probably couldn't even imagine a country, that would combine such great culture and technological advancement with such unspeakable and senseless cruelty. Perhaps they really didn't know she was alive. What happened to her must have had something to do with the Starstone. Did she know where he was? He definitely needs to get her sword back, that hasn't changed. But how to get it back?

The girl there summoned him. She just didn't remember doing that before. The image of that sword was burned into her memory as if by hellfire. However, she was sure that it was completely material. She felt its glow on her face... But still, this Adora, this She-Ra, wielded him. She was able to summon his power. She knew that just anyone couldn't do it, only those who were worthy. If this girl was worthy, it meant she wasn't that traitor, or at least not that perfidious. Perhaps she was somehow forced to abandon her... and take her sword from her. In the Azlanti labor camp, she learned that even good people can do terrible things. She was the best example of this herself. She did terrible things in her war with Azlanti and sometimes harmed innocents, although she tried to avoid it as much as she could. Perhaps she too was forced to abandon her and take her sword away… In that case, she could forgive her…. Of course, only if he returns this wonderful blade to its rightful owner. This was an indisputable fact.

It was also an indisputable fact that Lady Cala was not who she claimed to be. Or rather what she looked like. No one fought that well, was that fast and strong. And absolutely no one would take a direct flareshot to the face. But the worst thing was her look, cold and cruel , like a soulless creature. Every time she was hurt, she smiled with pure joy. Thanks to magic and the latest medicines, her wounds were already healed, but she was still in shock... And those kids... They were fighting on the side of this Adora against her crew... She didn't blame them either, after all, she wanted to hurt the woman they had grown to like without any a reason, at least one they knew... and besides, that cat girl saved her life with that gunshot that would have taken another creature's leg... She was sure it couldn't have been anyone who did it. They probably did not know the aristocrat's true identity, although from what she had already noticed, Eti treated Lady Cali with contemptuous dislike. There was also this Miss Daisy. She constantly felt like she knew her from somewhere, but if she was the queen, who could that woman be? Especially since she lived with a creature like Lady Cala…

As Tirin suggested, she went to Wherever. The advice turned out to be very accurate. The very fact that they ended up in this place had a great effect on the morale of the crew. They needed some entertainment. She knew that because of her recent behavior, she had lost a lot of the trust they had previously had in her. She knew very well that getting him back wouldn't be that easy, especially since she stopped trusting herself. Then, in Clytaimestra, she was overcome with unspeakable fury when the girl said that her sword was broken, she must finally get it back, but that was no reason to order the city to be shelled. She lost control, in the worst way possible. During her war with the Star Empire, she never went so far as to attack innocent civilians, even if they were Azlanti. She murdered representatives of the regime and soldiers of the Aeon Guard without blinking an eye, or sentenced them to slow death in the Gardens of the Long Death, but she had never crossed a certain line... Until now. This journey unleashed a darkness in her that she couldn't control.

Tonado, as fanatically devoted as ever, cleared the way for her. Skitterman was ready to shield her from being shot with his own breast. She turned, looking back, and saw Tirin looking at the gadgets at the stand. She was petite, even in the strange, suit-like armor Reh-zar had bought for her. She had pale skin, almost white, and navy blue, translucent hair unusual for Azlanti. The color of her hair was the result of contamination, or perhaps rather infection, that she fell victim to in early childhood. It was similar with their eyes, which were a uniform, crimson-blue color. Her body was a breeding ground for fungi and parasites that could only be contained thanks to the achievements of modern medicine. She liked the girl and was honestly glad she was finally off the ship. She was afraid to go out into the open, especially under the open sky, which was understandable for someone who grew up on a planet where going outside protected buildings could involve terrible suffering. However, in her case it was probably due to an accident that she barely survived when she was a small child. Luckily, Wherever was located in a huge cave carved inside the moon, which calmed the girl down. Tirin and Tonado aroused protective feelings in her, and together with Gozamund, they were the only crew members she trusted. Unfortunately, in case of any friction between her and the rest of the crew, the girl was the one who would most likely suffer the most. She had to be even more careful what she was doing now, lest Tirin become an accidental victim of an outburst of discontent because of her mistakes.

She left the navigator behind and, together with her officers, entered a bar called "Drink to the End". Inside, she was surprised to see Goblin. They were a ubiquitous species, with incredible ingenuity in creating machines from scrap and garbage, but she'd never heard of any of them running a bar, although then why not, goblins drank alcohol too. However, this one seemed to be much more focused than its brethren and had noticeable nostrils, which could indicate a hint of gnomish or halfling blood. He seemed clearly intimidated by the sight of her, which was good because it would make the conversation easier. She needed information. She stood over him and ordered something stronger. Drinking a strong

alcohol through a straw took some caution…she didn't want to choke, and asked.

“What do you know about Etheria?”

The bartender raised one eyebrow and smiled slightly as he replied.

“That its inhabitants are nice, but they can be tough and it's better not to pick on them if you value your skin.”

I noticed, she thought wryly, but continued to ask in a gentle voice

“I wanted to learn more about this planet.”

The goblin became lost in thought and looked at the captain searchingly and finally said.

“My girlfriend is from Etheria, she knows a lot more about it than I do.” he turned and called a woman named Hares . After a while, a woman with roses came out of the back room, smiling cheerfully and wiping her hands.

“What's the matter, honey?” she asked, then looked at her and froze. She opened her eyes wide.

“Who are you!? Take off your mask!” he will exclaim with a mixture of fear and hope. Tonado jumped on the bar and was about to threaten her with his blades, but she signaled him to stop and took off her mask. Hares took a deep breath, fell to her knees and said with joy.

-“Queen! My Queen... Are you alive? We all thought you were dead... That's when the portal opened.” she sobbed. Captain Moonshadow put her mask back on and looked at the horned woman, then asked curiously.

“Portal opened? Explain please.”

Hares looked surprised.

“You do not remember? That was when they took the Sword of Protection and…”

“Sword? My Sword? Where is it now!” she interrupted her mid-sentence. There was lust in her voice. Hares looked at her with confusion.

“Your sword? After all, it was Adora's Sword... And it was broken…” she exclaimed anxiously. The captain felt the icy claws of terror tightening around her heart. She remembered the words telling her to retrieve the sword if she wanted to remember her old life. These words rang in her ears, it felt like they would burst her skull. The world around her turned red, as if shrouded in the glow of ghostly eyes. She shook her head and pursed her lips. Ti didn't matter anyway. All that mattered was getting his sword back.

“You're lying!” she roared and jumped behind the bar. She grabbed the terrified horned woman by her clothes with a metal hand and pressed her hand surrounded by a solarian flare to her face.

“Tell the truth Where is the sword! Do you serve the invader?” she shouted. She saw her crew staring at her. The bartender tried to grab his gun, but Gydwa grabbed his arms and dragged him out from behind the bar, then pinned him to the floor.

“Invaders? You mean Hordak ?! After all, I have always served you faithfully. I was a student who came to Brightmoon with a group of sorcerers. For a few days I helped create the magical protections of your room, but I didn't do very well, and that's why I'm here. You do not remember?” Hares asked, her voice breaking.

“Sword… Hordak… Where can I find them!” she demanded, feeling like a headache was about to split her brain.

“Hordak is now on Beast Island. I don't know what they did with the remains of the sword. Maybe they gave them to Entrapta to examine them... Then it's on the Island too...”

When she heard Entrapta's name, she felt a sharp pang of sadness and pity. She knew this person and had feelings for him, but for some reason she was in the company of an Invader, this Hordak . Never mind. She came out from behind the bar and looked at her officers. They were confused, even Tonado. Gydwa exchanged glances with Kaert . She was aware that she had lost control of herself again. She looked around, there were only two customers in the bar and they were very careful not to be noticed. This time the situation might not have been so bad, but they had to be careful. The authorities of this place will not take kindly to the fact that someone starts fights and intimidates entrepreneurs.

“Bind everyone here. Tonado, you'll be guarding the doors and telling everyone the bar is closed due to plumbing problems. Meeting on deck in six hours.” she said in a low voice.

“Queen… Please… Return home … Glimmer is waiting for you there.”

She turned and looked at the woman. Glimmer. That was her daughter's name. She looked at her hands and shuddered. She couldn't remember what kind of person she used to be, but she was definitely different from the Scourge of Azlanti. Better.

“Queen Angela is dead. She died in the Azlantean labor camp. There, Captain Moonshadow was born. She is the Queen of Shadows. Nobody More.” she said and left the bar more lost than ever.

Discussions at the table, part one

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She woke up.

For a moment, she thought she was in her room in the Kingdom of Snow. There was nice and warm, and Shogi was sleeping as a cat-like creature on her legs and snoring. And then she saw the plants in pots and the shield with the coat of arms, she realized where she was and she was overcome with inexpressible sadness and shame. She lost her kingdom. She was just Frosta now, nobody else. She didn't even have a home because her subjects... Her people didn't want her. She couldn't even take her things with her, she only had what she managed to take with her on the trip, mainly a change of clothes. She didn't even have any sanitary pads with her, and it turned out that she had her period last night. The first time it happened was during the war and Glimmer helped her a lot... She didn't want to think about her friend, so she quickly dressed in the clothes Spinnerella and Netossa had prepared for her. She grimaced because he was much too big, or maybe she was too short? The inhabitants of the Kingdom of Snow were shorter, than the citizens of other kingdoms, regardless of what People they belonged to. She felt strange in this outfit, she usually tried to wear the ethnic clothes of her kingdom. This was to help her win over the clan representatives and prove that she was devoted to them and that the culture of her kingdom was the most important to her. It probably didn't work after all... Maybe if she wore those stupid and uncomfortable outfits she wore during state ceremonies every day... Would she then be… Respectable enough? Would she represent her kingdom and her subjects appropriately? Probably not, the problem was in a completely different place. In her. She sighed, then smiled slightly as Shogi began to chirp and rub against her legs.

“I guess we have to go, because they're probably waiting for us.” she said to her companion and left the room into the dining room.

It turned out that breakfast was not ready yet. In the evening , Spinnerella told Netossa that she missed her very much with THAT voice, so they probably went to sleep VERY late. She wonder if someone will ever address her this way? She had never thought about it before. It didn't matter anyway. Netossa was feeding the Child porridge from a pot, Spinnerella was busy serving food despite her condition, Greypaw was nodding off, and Quickling was listening to the radio. She took a deep breath, put on the most serious face she could, and said solemnly.

“I greet the people in charge of this household and I thank you with all my heart for the honor of spending the night by their fire, which saved me from certain death from the cold.”

All five of them, including the Child, looked at her with their mouths open, and Netossa looked suspiciously out the window, as if to check if the weather had changed.

“Oh Frosta ! You don't have to address us formally. It is our pleasure to host you under our roof.” said the ruler of Windcrest, smiling friendly.

“Shogi!” Greypaw and Quickling shouted as they ran towards the shapeshifting creature, which now took on a more dog-like form. They had been playing with him all evening yesterday, although Netossa was a bit wary, after all, she had seen her new friend in Shogoth's natural form . Eventually, however, she decided that there was no threat to anyone from the ancient creature and began tossing him a ball for him to fetch. She almost forgot what happened to her then.

“Children, you haven't forgotten something.” Spinnrella asked , looking at the children in a significant way.

“Good morning Princess Frosta!” Greypaw and Quickling replied at the same time, without ceasing to

petting Shogi.

“We need to think about getting them a pet.” Netossa suggested, and her wife smiled warmly.

There were not many servants in the court of the united kingdom. Although dinners were prepared by the cook, both rulers tried to prepare breakfasts themselves, although due to Spinnerella's advanced stage of pregnancy , this will probably change soon. Vegan banana pancakes and rolls with tofu and sweet filling and vegetable broth were served, and she and Greypaw got milk soup with buckwheat noodles. She sat down next to the place occupied by the cat-like boy, who returned to his seat after a while. He was very different from Catra, just like all the other feline people she had ever met. She had never actually met anyone like Catra, but she had never been to Scorpion country for long. Her people probably lived there. Greypaw asked for a cup of almond milk and when he got it he asked.

“Frosta … I mean, Princess Frosta. Can you still cool the milk for me? Because you don't rule the Kingdom of Snow anymore, do you?

His question was innocent but fully justified, after all it was said that the power of runestones could not be wielded by those who proved themselves unworthy. And since she turned out to be unworthy of ruling her kingdom... She was shocked to find that she didn't remember using her power since she lost control there, in front of the ice palace. Terrified, she grabbed Greypaw's mug and froze it so violently that it cracked. Instead of relief at having retained her powers, she felt shame at having destroyed the mug. She lowered her head and remained gloomily silent. Spinnerella looked at her son disapprovingly and said.

“In the thousands of years since... Since the First Ones left Etheria, only a few times have any of the princesses been deprived of the Power. Talon of Brightmoon wanted to turn into a not-dead sorcerer to rule forever and murdered seven people. Scythe of Dryll carried out terrible experiments, Misty of Plumeria

named herself the Princess in Yellow and began to distort her kingdom with Dark Magic, and Iron Grasp, Scorpia's ancestor, was simply a crazy Tyrant who wanted to enslave all the inhabitants of Etheria, ruined the reputation her people for many years " The ruler of Windcrest explained to everyone with passion. Quickling's eyes lit up with curiosity.

"Is Entrapta... Princess Entrapta has her own Runestone?" Saihe the girl asked .

"No, it was destroyed during the time of Princess Scythe by her daughter. It allowed for combining organic and inanimate matter, creating a connection between living beings and machines. Supposedly, there were eight runestones that gave powers, but only five survived... " she did not add that these five were enough to almost destroy their world. "Not all princesses who use the power have access to Runestones. I inherited mine from Ariel, Queen Angela's sister, Mom Netossa can make webs thanks to ancient technology, and Princess Sweet Bee can communicate telepathically... I'm not sure how, but I think it has something to do with her origins." Spinnerella explained . The rest of breakfast passed in silence. When Queen Angela was mentioned, she felt very sad. Her parents died when she was little and she had virtually no memory of them. It was hard to miss someone you barely remembered. And Glimmer lost her mother, whom she loved so much, and in such terrible circumstances.

Both princesses had been almost deprived of their own property during their years of exile in Brightmoon, and they did not want to abuse the Queen's hospitality and took care of most of the household chores on their own, and decided that nothing would change for them in this respect once their homelands were regained and united. After all, Their people had suffered so much during the war that it was inappropriate for them to live in comfort and luxury now. She asked to be allowed to help them, although she had only washed her plate during the last trip, so she didn't put much effort into it, but she wanted to be useful. At first, Netossa protested that she was a guest and didn't have to do anything for them, but Spinnerella said that it was great that

she would help them. While she was washing up, Shogi was watching over the Child. The job helped her and made her feel a little better. However, once the dishes were done, she went into the living room to listen to the radio, but the only news was the Chancellor's speech about the great future of their new republic. She immediately lost her mood. Netossa swore so badly that she thought her ears were going to fall off, so she turned off the radio and then growled.

“Damn, Lonnie. That we also let her minions get away with it. They all had to be tied up and taken to the dungeon! They would fraternize with the rats!” She spoke until her wife put her hand on her shoulder.

“Kyle seems like the kind of guy who would befriend with rats, but Scarlet... I thought she was my friend. She saved my life even though she didn't have to.” She didn't add that she knew the truth about Nightgale. Maybe there was a secret here? She was the daughter of Shadow Weaver, who was a liar and a manipulator… No, that wouldn't be fair. No one should be judged for who her mother was. They didn't know everything.” Maybe it's not her or Lonnie's doing. But what do I know?I thought the Chancellor was my friend too.”

Calamity would never have thought that at the sight of another feline creature, her heart would burn with such a hot fire of Righteous Wrath. The younger one, that Eti, for understandable reasons aroused in her hatred mixed with well-deserved contempt. But it was nothing, the mere glow of a candle flame in the bright sunlight. This creature took away her future, broke out her destiny. She made her wonderful Existence meaningless. She could have become the undisputed ruler of Etheria, or perhaps this part of the universe, but she was only an element of Nyarlathotep's plan, one of many. What a pathetic fall. Could she have been further disgraced? And worst of all, she could not seek justice in any way. Just stand here and smile benevolently, because that was the sorceress's plan. It was only with the

greatest effort of will that she stopped herself from tearing out her throat with her bone claws. How long will her torment last?

The conversation with Heart Gift turned out to be quite fruitful. The AI was dumb even compared to the mortals, but she still didn't want to arouse her suspicions, lest she summon those damned crabs to tear her apart. That would be more than troublesome. Fortunately, she was able to be nice and hide her true nature, although she was tempted to tell the AI the truth about her mothers, but she came up with a much funnier idea... Perhaps she could even find a way to circumvent the agreement between Nyarlathotep and the Dark Sorceress. The power node map was interesting and will greatly help them with their grand plan. She said goodbye to Heart Gift, promising her that they would meet again. She intended to keep this promise...

The journey back to the vehicles that had brought them here was much shorter than it had been to get there, mainly because she no longer had to limit herself and could use the full potential of her perfect body. She got into the mercenary's vehicle in case her own was mined. You can't fall into the same trap again. She also notified friendly cultists who were to take care of her former friends trapped in the shelter, who, according to the words of the unwise AI, survived. She was happy because she had prepared something special for them…

She reached a small town where the house of her most important contact was, Klementine , the daughter of General Jocelyn . The girl was waiting for her outside the city, dressed in the rather pretentious robes of a Nyarlathotep cultist, put on hastily considering how disorganized they were. She greeted her with such sincere joy that Calamity wasn't sure if the girl understood who she was dealing with, or even what being a cultist meant. She decided that she was one of those naive creatures who looked for comfort and answers to their sadness and uncertainty in cults. Well, she could play that role, there you go, Shadow Weaver taught her how to play a savior and a benevolent protector.

The greeting was hurried, but she must have made the right impression, because the girl blushed when she spoke to her. This will be easier than she expected. Klementine wanted to take her to her house to entertain her, but she refused. She told her to change her clothes and provide herself with a suitable outfit so that she could meet the queen. The girl looked a bit disappointed, but complied. Well, she wasn't chosen because of her talents, but because of the position her mother held. Despite what she probably believed, her position in the cult was quite low. She didn't really need it to get into Glimmer's presence, her name alone should have been enough, but she decided it was worth keeping this acquaintance because it would come in handy someday. The servants were only a little surprised when Klementine brought such a guest at night, but the instructions for the girl to pack because they were going to Brightmoon made a much greater impression . During the flight she held onto it tightly, tighter than she had to, and while walking through the corridors of the castle she chattered incoherently. She kindly kept her talking, even though she wanted to pull out all her teeth and shove them down the girl's throat.

The chatter stopped when they met Catra and her three companions. She recognized Castaspella by the fact that she wore the head sorcerer's crown, which, like the sorceress herself, was carefully described to her by Shadow Weaver. She didn't have a very good opinion of the new ruler Mystacor , although now Calamity decided that she was too kind to her anyway. Behind her stood a woman who stared at her with amazement tinged with reverent respect. She was even taller than her, her face was hidden behind an illusory disguise, a very good one by the way, but most importantly, she had a mark that allowed the aristocrat to recognize her as an servant of the Creeping Chaos. The third individual was the most interesting. At first she thought it was an elf-blooded tiefling, but then she saw that it was translucent and floating in the air. Unimaginable power emanated from him, and there was pure evil in his eyes. She liked him immediately. When he noticed that she saw him, he looked surprised, then bowed and signaled her to remain silent.

“I heard about you, Adora told me about your meeting on Icarus. Catra said, wrinkling her nose slightly. She forgot to use smell suppressants. She sensed distrust in her eyes. Did she suspect something? But before she could answer the feline woman, she felt a painful burst of magic, not as bad as She- Ra's , but still painful like any Etherian magic, and Glimmer appeared next to her.

“Oh, I have a great idea. We'll make dinner together! I invited your father too! Oh, who are you?” The Queen looked at her surprised.

Shadow Weaver has been underinformed again.

Lady Ka sometimes thought that the Lord Admiral should get himself a butler or an adjutant. Actually, Commander Reese had been his adjutant before he became Commander, but he had been promoted and, to her regret, he had performed his duties well. Although if the Lord Admiral wasn't such a damn handsome guy, she would have had a lot more objections. On the other hand, the whole ritual was not about getting dressed, but about an excuse to discuss matters that were important to both of them. And there have been quite a lot of them recently.

“It seems Lady Cala hasn't been completely honest with us...” she muttered to the Lord Admiral, straightening his cuffs. They were getting ready for a formal dinner, during which they could learn some Etherian customs and get to know each other better. The problem was that there were several people invited who were not expected to be there.

“To be honest, I didn't expect anything else. Nobody, who goes to such a place without hiding any secrets. However, I had no idea that Miss Daisy could come from this planet and, in addition, be someone who played such an important role in the history of this planet... And in the life of my daughter. However, it must be admitted that it explains a lot. It's no wonder that an aristocrat

like Lady Cala decided to go on this expedition. The only question is how aware she was of her mentor's true nature. If so, it means that he is a much more calculating and ambitious person than we thought. And much more dangerous. For now, we have to pretend to be more unaware than we are." The Lord Admiral said thoughtfully. She nodded and said, smiling sarcastically.

"In the case of our Ashurk, it would be quite difficult. Good thing this idiot has no idea about anything important."

"Distribute the truth according to competence." Antares said thoughtfully. "But what does the Aristocrat want? Rather, among fairy tales we can include stories about the desire to experience adventure and get to know the place where one comes from. However, there remains the question of this gift. What could he be... If Miss Daisy is indeed the Shadow Weaver, she may have come here to take revenge on my daughter and her fiancée.. We cannot allow this under any circumstances!" said the Lord Admiral with the promise of a slow and painful death. "But as for the other inhabitants of Etheri… Well, I'm very sorry for what will happen to them." he added in a gentler tone.

Lady Ka tried to keep a straight face. Would she try to save the new kitten if that grim sorceress tried to kill it? She wasn't sure about the answer to this question/=. After all, this way she would solve most of her problems and her hands would still be clean. At least in the Admiral's eyes. New kitty, this Catra was undoubtedly smart and very dangerous. And her claws... She tried very hard not to touch the mask... Could she count on her being allowed to keep her position if necessary? Rather unlikely, although it would also depend on what the Lord Admiral's plan was. Perhaps he will direct events so that the girl has no choice. As he said, both war and politics were largely about creating order out of chaos, and this planet was a veritable melting pot.

Right after an overly long breakfast with her boss's daughter and an irritating conversation with the purple-haired idiot, she decided to look around the palace. The guards were vigilant and watching her, but since she was part of the entourage of their commander's

father, they didn't really know how to deal with her, so they didn't stop her wherever she went... But she wasn't sure if there was even a single place in this castle which she would like to visit. In fact, she has never been to any palace or castle, apart from the absurd and grotesque residence of Jantar. She was a city girl and the city was her element, her natural environment, her feeding ground. What was she supposed to do in the fucking queen's abode. Picking up damn princesses? If they were all like that purple-haired nosy idiot, then she'd say thank to this idea, she wasn't that desperate and she respected herself too much. So she had to use simpler methods. She could read lips and had good hearing, and the servants here liked to gossip as much as anyone else. She also had some hard currency and gadgets for bribes and gifts, and she knew the basics of hacking, so she could break into private computers without much effort... Although, as it later turned out, the inhabitants of Etheria did not know the concept of digital security. Well, their loss. She learned the most by eavesdropping on the kitchen helpers' conversations. The cook even offered her soup, claiming that it looked unhealthy. She was pale, a bit emaciated, and the only visible eye was bloodshot and puffy, but let's be honest. Who is a normal person who offers soup to strangers? She probably wanted to drug her to get information from her. And even if she didn't, she still couldn't bring herself to eat something she hadn't prepared herself. The price of being raised by Jantar, or perhaps the price of wisdom, depends on how you look at it. So she poured the contents of the soup into the fountain, but first she asked the woman about this and that. She was talkative and suspiciously protective, probably trying to get her into bed, but at least she learned some interesting things. First of all, Lady Cala and Asindesa Di Vir arrived at the castle . They were alone without an entourage and it was unknown whether they knew about the Lord Admiral's arrival. They kept the entire expedition a secret, although not very secret. Neither Prime's heirs nor the Hellknights had noteworthy intelligence. She also learned something else. Apparently something happened in the castle at night. Some sort of burglary, sabotage, or maybe even an attempt to kidnap the queen. They claimed that some sort of People's Rebellion was responsible for this, although there

was a thought in the back of her mind that she decided to keep to herself for now.

“I wonder how much our noble knight knows and understands? Maybe we should ask her about it? I'm sure she has something to do with that dark sorceress.” she said, tying the scarf behind the Lord Admiral's neck.

“Hell Knights are widely known for fraternizing with the forces of Darkness to achieve goals that further their cause. The Order of the Eclipse may not do this as often as other orders, but I have seen knights and men-at-arms go into battle alongside Devils and the undead.” Said the commander of the Fearless Armada thoughtfully. “I don't criticize them for that. In war, you must do what is necessary to win. Especially in the war we were fighting. When you face an opponent like the Swarm, you cannot hesitate to use even the most terrible weapons. However, if the Order is associated with the Shadow Weaver, or rather the Shadow Weaver is associated with the Order... This will be the second time they have withheld important information from us, and worse still, we still don't know what they are hiding from us. We cannot tolerate this.” Anteres voice became hard, almost angry. She didn't tell her commander that they too had withheld important information, perhaps even much more important information, from the rest of the fleet. Her boss was an understanding man, but she preferred not to abuse this understanding.

“There is something else, from what I heard, there was an incident here at night. The locals suspect that the opposition to the Queen, some People's Rebellion or something is responsible for this, but I have my suspicions. Something tells me your other daughter may have been responsible for this. – She said, helping her commander put on his shoes, although she would take them off before sitting down at the table. So it was a waste of time, and he usually dealt with it himself, but she decided to take advantage of the opportunity and talk to her commander for a while.

“On what basis did you draw such an interesting conclusion?” the Lord Admiral asked with obvious interest in his voice.

“Mainly based on hunch. We know that they went to the zone and that your old friend Doctor Sidonius, who has always been fascinated by the First Ones is helping them hide. And in the entire region there is no place more interesting than Etheria. It may be a large planet, but such a break-in suits both my sister and... your younger daughter.”

The Lord Admiral thought for a long moment before speaking.

“We need to get the girl back into our hands as soon as possible. Not just because of the artifact. She is the blood of my blood. I can't let her forget her destiny. Our bloodline will be safer with both of them. Besides, maybe one day her sister will need support. Right hand. Someone who will be willing to do things that she officially cannot afford.”

Someone like me, Lady Ka thought bitterly. The Lord Admiral looked at her mysteriously, as if he had read her thoughts, and said.

“Getting her back is not a priority right now. It is not worth chasing two hares at the same time, because you will be hungry in the evening. If you're right and the girl is here, she won't be leaving this planet any time soon. Especially if she knows about her sister... I wonder what she's looking for here, or rather what the Doctor is looking for here... It doesn't matter now anyway. The girl will fall into our hands sooner or later. Just remember.” his voice now became very cold, a bit growly, threatening. “Not even the slightest harm can come to her. Whatever you do to her, you will receive tenfold. The same applies to her companions, as long as they are not Tarak shadows ... Although you can beat them up a bit, but I will need them as... a way of pressuring her to listen to our commands more willingly.”

“What about my sister... That traitorous bitch.” she drawled, barely able to control her fury. The Lord Admiral almost smiled as he said.

“You serve me faithfully, let her life be your reward...”

She smiled with the visible half of her mouth, extremely cruel, even for her.

Chapter End Notes

And again I divide the chapter into two parts. Please leave your comments and opinions.

Discussions at the table, part two.

Chapter Notes

> And here is a new chapter. I hope Adora didn't come off as too much of a taciturn here. Feel free to comment and give feedback.

She was very happy that they are returning to Etheria. This stay on Icarus went badly from the beginning. First, Perfuma was exhausted of bringing the land back to life, then she had a fight with those strange kids, although that ended quite happily. They also met Wrong Hordak. She knew that the clone had set out a few years ago on a great expedition to discover what lay beyond the Empire. Catra was very skeptical and suggested that Hordak wanted to get rid of his younger brother to be alone with Entrapta. However, it turned out that he came back safe and sound... and very nicely dressed! But then they met this beautiful woman, Lady Cala . She didn't even look at them when she talked to Adora , but she still made a stunning impression on her... She was so... Distinguished. Yes, that's the right word. She was like Glimmer, only much more so. But after a while, Queen Angela appeared... She turned out to be a pirate and said she wanted to kill Adora . She had never met the Queen before, only knowing her from Horde propaganda materials, which were... Well, far from the truth. But she was sure she wasn't that kind of person. Someone who would be ready to burn down an entire city along with its inhabitants. This… this was like when she served in the Horde. On Hordak's, Shadow Weaver’s and... Catra’s orders they did many terrible things, although she found out about many of them only after the war... But Queen Angela would never hurt anyone innocent, she was Glimmer's mother and the fearless leader of the rebellion. Even Hordak had begrudging respect for her. After they repelled the pirates, Lady Cala came with a dead

baby in her arms. She said that Queen Angela murdered them to escape from the aristocrat. Then the most amazing thing in her life happened, and she experienced many amazing things, such as becoming a princess and meeting the most wonderful woman in the world. Adora used She-Ra's power to bring her back to life. She had heard from Glimmer that something similar had happened during Catra's release from Horde Prime's ship, though Catra denied it.

Cala then told the story of Angela, or rather Captain Moonshadow. It wasn't a happy story, she wouldn't wish this fate on anyone. She didn't understand everything the woman was talking about. What was the Azlanti Empire? Why did they imprison the queen? And who needed new empires? But then Adora got scared, said something about the shadow of the moon, and disappeared in a flash of light. Immediately afterwards, Lady Cala had to leave with her friends, leaving them alone to deal with all the commotion. First they had to calm down the guards because several of them became hysterical. They shouted that the great She-Ra had abandoned them for their sins and now they were all condemned . They tried to calm them down, which wasn't easy, apparently the fact that Adora saved that child made them worship her even more... Almost like the Clones worshiped Horde Prime ... Not only the clones, she knew something about it too... She felt sorry for her friend, who never wanted to be treated this way, hated to be worshipped like a deity... Fortunately, she managed to calm the guards down, although it required a lot of hugging and talking in a quiet, calm voice about how Adora wasn't mad at them and they were doing a great job. As soon as they managed to deal with one problem, more soldiers came, this time much less friendly, and a sad lady intelligence officer. Perfuma was a bit scared, but she knew well how to talk to officers, after all, she was one of them herself. The interrogation lasted several hours, but finally the republic's authorities decided they had no more questions and let them go, although fortunately no one brought up the topic of Queen Angela. Maybe that's what they should have been worried about after all... They were escorted to Darla right after. Fortunately, because the terrified inhabitants of the city took to

the streets talking about Prime's return or the appearance of an invasion fleet from outside the Empire. She wished she could explain everything to them, but she didn't really know what she should say. She wanted to turn to her wife to help her calm down the situation, Perfuma always knew what to say to make others feel happy, but this time she was exhausted and depressed, so she thought it would be best if they left as soon as possible.

She always felt unsecure on board of Darla. She was always a bit clumsy and sometimes broke things by accident. In the Fright Zone it didn't matter much anyway, because everything was falling apart anyway, but it was the Darla , an ancient First Ones ship, probably the last one of its kind in the world. If something breaks in it, it will break for good, maybe Entrapta will be able to fix it, only then she will have to explain to her friend that she damaged her thousands-year-old ship. Darla herself wasn't helping her either. The ship was mainly obediend Entrapta and Adora, although it was instructed to also obey her and her wife's orders... Only it did so very reluctantly. After these few years, Darla developed quite a peculiar... personality. She became very grumpy, snarky and generally rude... at least to her. She felt like he resented her for being a scorpion. She wasn't sure what had happened between the First Ones, Mara, and her people, but it had made Darla not very nice to her.

What worried her most was Perfuma's condition. Her wife was grimm, even gloomy, not like her. She tried to comfort her, first she suggested a game night, and when she refused, she suggested another form of relaxation... But she didn't want to do that either... Finally, being seriously worried, she made her the herbal tea she always liked. They were flying in a relatively safe part of space, so she could leave the piloting to Darla, although she snorted and started grumbling about everything falling on her head. Perfuma smiled gratefully at her and thanked her. She sat down next to her and asked in a concerned voice.

„What happened honey?”

Her wife looked at her with sadness in her eyes and sighed.

„I had a dream. I saw a destroyed planet there. A man who sang about suffering and... the embodiment of kindness and friendship. She introduced herself as Hylax. She warned me. I don't know if it's true, maybe it was just a dream, but these kids talked about it too... and about this planet, because it was their home. I saw their home. Destroyed.” she looked at her, fear and despair in her eyes. “Destroyed by the Hunger That Cannot Be Satiated”.

„Dinner with your father is not something I thought would happen to me.” Adora said, combing her hair. She smiled and replied to her fiancée.

„I never thought I would take part in it either...„ she said with gloomy resignation in her voice. “I've always been an orphan from the Fright Zone, and I can't think of myself as having a family. It was just you and me. Two girls together against the world, although now rather wandering through the world together. It won't be like this anymore... I'm not sure whether to be happy about it.” she turned to her beloved and looked into her eyes, in which she saw comforting joy.

„Find something good in it. Now you will have someone to lead you to the wedding.„ she said. On Etheri, young couples were usually led by their parents, or someone who played a similar role in their lives, to encourage them in their final declaration of love in the moonlight.

„I thought about asking Mikah to lead me and Glimmer together, but I figured I shouldn't take up her moment. Besides you, then you would be alone, so I thought we would be together. We will lead ourselves to the wedding, right?” she smiled, as if amused by what she said. But she soon became serious. „ Now you will be alone while I... „ she looked at Adora's eyes and saw pain in them. Her dearest always secretly dreamed that she had a family somewhere out there in the universe. Parents who mourn a child taken from them by Light Hope, or at least her compatriots. At the same time, she was very afraid of it because of what terrible

things the First Ones had done to Etheria and the Galaxy. But now she, her beloved, has found her family, even though she never wanted it. „You know, I think I should have refused him... „ She said with guilt in her voice, but Adora put her hand on her shoulder and said.

„That would be stupid... Just because I'm alone... That doesn't mean you have to, too. Think about it in a practical way. Glimmer wanted you to bond with him because he might be needed. Anyway, I can always ask Lady Cala."

She grimaced and said.

„I don't like her... There's something about her... It makes the hairs on the back of my neck stand on end. And, I know this sounds stupid, but I don't like the smell of it. I've inhaled many stenches in the Fright Zone, but this one is much worse. Not even disgusting, just… Inappropriate… Unnatural. Nobody should smell like that." she shuddered. Her meeting with Lady Cala Grayskull was short. Right after they exchanged the first pleasantries, Glimmer showed up and invited her to dinner. Immediately after that, Catra went to her office to read reports of recent events and give orders to the guards to improve the security of the castle, and she also wanted to draw up an order to hire someone to take care of securing the computers, but she didn't have time because she had to get ready for this dinne , although due to the last expedition she was terribly behind in work. "You know, it's weird, but I have the impression that lady inch smells a bit like Shogi . Not identical, but somehow similar." she said, and Melog looked up as she mentioned Frosta's shapeshifting friend. Her companion was sleeping on the couch, listening intently. He didn't like Lady Cala either. He claimed that it exuded something evil that should not exist in this world, although he did not explain exactly what. But she was sure she agreed with him.

„Do you think it's related to her? To Shadow Weaver? That she is a ward just like us? That we should help her, maybe even save her?„ she asked her beloved. Adora thought for a moment before answering.

„ I'm not sure. She is… very beautiful and strong and educated. He has everything that I will never have, no matter how hard I try.

She rolled her eyes and huffed in irritation.

„Don't go back to "I'm not good enough" again, okay?„ She walked up to her and took her face in her hands and added „ You're the best, not only for me... Damn, I'm starting to hate this woman for making you think so.„ she kissed her beloved. When they broke apart, Adora added thoughtfully.

„I don't know what her relationship with Shadow Weaver might be like, but she definitely didn't treat her like she treated us. Lady Cala is strong and confident. There is not an ounce of fear and uncertainty that she instilled in us. I envy her a bit. But I feel like if Shadow Weaver could create a ward from scratch, it would be just like her. Plus lack of conscience and ruthlessness. If she could, she would probably add claws and some monstrous powers.” She smiled at the last mention, and Catra grimaced.

„Yes, then she would be a real mommy's girl.” and they started giggling, although it wasn't actually funny. They sat on the bed and she rested her head on Adora's shoulder and began to purr. Melog rested his head on his lap. After a while, her beloved asked in a low voice

„What do you think about your father?”

She grimaced. Earlier, she had repeated to Adora a condensed version of what she had learned from the Lord Admiral. Her beloved listened carefully to the entire story in silence. She didn't comment a word on what she had learned, waiting for her opinion. Only she didn't know what to think about it all.

„I don't know, to be honest. He seems to be a strong and dangerous individual. He also has a majesty to him that Hordak or even Horde Prime could have” dreamed of... His story also

explains a lot about my story. Why am I so fit and always ready to fight..

„And you know what's best about all this?” said Adora, smiling slyly.

„What?„ she asked suspiciously.

„That now you are a princess too!”

„I'll scratch your eyes out for this insult.” She playfully pretended to scratch Adora's face and then kissed her beloved again. But then, in a flash of light, Glimmer appeared.

„ Scorpia and Perfuma just arrived... I didn't interrupt anything, did I?

She had to admit that she hated spaceflight. Being locked in a dead piece of metal in the middle of a cold, dark void. However, she loved visiting other planets, so full of life, unknown and wonderful, and meeting their inhabitants, learning their customs and traditions. The problem, of course, was that you couldn't visit other planets without going into space. So she had to endure this inconvenience and until now she had managed somehow, but this time it was really hard. First of all , Darla was extremely rude to Scorpia this time . She was convinced that the AI was deliberately taking advantage of her shyness because she was afraid of damaging or offending the ship as it was partially owned by her best friend. In fact, she wondered if Darla was jealous of Entrapta, or maybe it was Hordak's bad influence? She wanted to yell at her in private, but she didn't feel well. Her spouse thought it was because of what happened with Adora and Angela , which was partially true, but that wasn't the only thing. There was this dream, a terrible one ... but she was also afraid that it held far too much truth. At first she hoped it was just a nightmare caused by the exhaustion of earth healing, but then she met those kids. They were militant, yet they emanated so much pain... They lost

their planet. Their world, everything they had. They had nothing left behind them. It was difficult to imagine such a tragedy. For them, the inhabitants of Etheria, not to mention Icarus, the war was terrible, but at least they won it. They had something to rebuild, something to return to. They... There were no words to describe what she felt looking at them. She wanted to ask them about the Swarm, what it was and how to fight it, but how could she ask the victims about who would hurt them? She might have to do it after all. She knew a little about the Swarm from this Hylax, and she had seen a little in her dreams, but it wasn't enough. She needed to find out more, even though she hated talking or even thinking about the war. However, before she had the opportunity to learn more, there was a clash with Queen Angela, who for some reason wanted to kill Adora . She didn't understand anything about what happened then, but she didn't even have a chance to think about it because pirates attacked them. She had to fight a little furry creature that would have been cute under any other circumstances, but now it just wanted to chop her to pieces. They managed to fend them off, but then Lady Cala brought in this dead baby that Adora somehow saved, and then they all left and they had to deal with all the chaos. Only then could they make their way back to Etheria.

On board Darla, she talked to her Wife about her dream, but she couldn't tell her everything she saw? She didn't know the words to describe the horror she experienced then. She has always loved beauty and peace, the harmony between all living things. And that was doom roaming through the universe like the Galactic Horde, only unstoppable. How could she tell her friends that there was another evil in the universe, as terrible as the one that had cost them so much to defeat. Adora would probably want to face the Swarm immediately, no matter what it would cost her. She had to return to Plumeria and think everything over, meditate in peace, trying to unite with the universe, to find out the answers to the questions that bothered her.

She was not allowed to rest in peace. First they had to go to Brightmoon, in case Adora hadn't returned yet, to tell Glimmer the

news about her mother. As soon as they landed, the Queen appeared next to them. Who, hugging them, called joyfully.

„Great to have you here. I have to take you to the castle soon so you can freshen up, because we don't have much time! I invite you to a joint, solemn and official dinner with Catra's dad!”

She liked the idea of having dinner together more and more. Not only that. She will get to know their new guests better and will also have the opportunity to confront them with each other. She was genuinely curious about who the other members of the Fleet were, especially Lady Cala. The aristocrat fit perfectly into what Adora had said about her... She looked like... Like She-Ra... If she were an ordinary human and not a magical being in Adora's body... I guess... No one was really sure who or what she actually was… is She-Ra… All they learned was that she had existed long before the First Ones arrived, perhaps since forever. One day they will have to discover the truth, but was it safe to dig into the secrets of the past again? She knew all too well what evil they could reveal... And Lady Cala was so... similar to what She-Ra was supposed to look like according to old drawings and traditional legends, that if she had shown up in Brightmoon six years ago, dressed appropriately and claiming to be She-Ra, no one would doubt that she was telling the truth. And that was what made her not trust her in the slightest.

Dinner, or rather supper-dinner, was served around seven o'clock... It was strange, but she couldn't believe that not even twenty-four hours had passed since it all started. The servants did not prepare a sumptuous feast because she did not want to bother them too much with unannounced work. So all that was served was soup of seafood and cream, and chickpea meatballs, along with cider and fruit... although she had an irresistible craving for sauerkraut, as sharply sour as an axe. so she ordered it to be served too. The Lord Admiral arrived with Lady Ka, Lady Cala and Asindesa Di Vir. She also invited her aunt, who also brought her assistant, this damn tall woman named Nightgale .

There was also Entrapta, who decided to stay in Brightmoon, clearly fascinated by the guests. With her came that strange ant with ribbons on her head, although she didn't actually invite her, but she preferred not to ask her leave, because apparently she also played some role in the Lord Admiral's entourage, although she had no idea what. There were of course Scorpia and Perfuma who had just arrived. They looked very tired, especially Perfuma. She wasn't sure if she had done the right thing by inviting them right after such a long journey, before they had time to rest, but on the other hand, it was inappropriate for her not to invite them to such an extremely important meeting. They were very happy to learn that they would meet Catra's father, although the fact that he was not a feline creature surprised them, and Scorpia stiffened at the sight of the uniform. She immediately saw that there was tension between the Lord Admiral, the Lady of Blades, and Lady Cala , although the blonde beauty was more composed than the other two.

At first they just talked about ordinary, unimportant things. The atmosphere was nice and cheerful. Entrapta was eating her Falafels, which had been cut into small pieces by someone with a good head on their shoulders. She sat staring at her datapad , while the ant that introduced itself as Ashurk stared at its smaller datapad, chirping incoherently with its mandibles, and took photos and videos of everyone. She has already asked her three times when they are going to install the network in her castle. Lady Ka sat next to the Lord Admiral, but did not eat anything, keeping one eye on the other guests.

“Entrapta, do you happen to know how the Child is doing?" She asked, smiling friendly. The inventor looked at her surprised.”

„Child? What Child?... Aah, that Child, that mine... Everything is fine with it. Hordak loves taking care of it. He's a really wonderful father, you know?” she said with pure delight.

„Is your husband the former commander of the local Horde? Very interesting. I should meet him sometime. I would talk to him about the Horde, like leader to leader.” said the Lord Admiral.

„There are many clones on Etheri that you could talk to, Lord Admiral.” she said, but Entrapta interrupted .

„Oh, that's wonderful, because very rarely does anyone visit us. We will welcome you with joy ! – Entrapta exclaimed with pure delight. He grimaced because she was right. Because of her husband, they visited her far too rarely.

„Hordak, unlike other clones, knows quite a lot about command, so the information he has may prove particularly valuable, because most enemies of both, the Etherians and my fleet, are Horde Prime's former "little brothers".” Catra's father said

"However, Hordak..." she began, her tone sharp, but Bow interrupted her

„He has been loyal to the kingdom of Etheria for five years and so far has not given us the slightest reason to suspect him of anything, and of all the clones, he has the most reason to oppose Prime's heirs , so he will be happy to help you .

She glared at her fiancé because she hated being interrupted, but after a while she realized that he was right. Whatever she thought of the former ruler of the Etherian Horde, he hated Horde Prime more than anyone else, and according to both Horde Ultimate and the Heavenly Brothers, he was a traitor who deserved a slow and painful death. She nodded, and then for a full fifteen minutes Entrapta told everyone about her new castle, Beast Island, her husband, and her Child, in that exact order. Finally the Lord Admiral turned to his daughter.

„I see you don't drink alcohol.” the Lord Admiral asked his daughter, pointing to the cup of milk in the feline girl's hand, who smiled sadly.

„After Horde Prime chipped me, I don't like anything that would cloud my mind. But even before that I avoided alcohol. The woman who raised us, Shadow Weaver, was a mean drunk. I prefer not to follow her example in any matter.” she said firmly.

Then Glimmer noticed that two people seemed moved at the sound of the gloomy Sorceress's name. One of them was her aunt, which was understandable. Her relationship with Hordak's Right Hand Man was complicated. On the one hand, she had great respect for her, but on the other, she didn't forgive her for what she did to Mikah ... But why did the hell knight also react? Although she kept a straight face, her hand twitched and she almost spilled the soup.

„Speaking of alcohol abuse, apparently your mentor, Miss Daisy, also had a drinking problem, am I right, Lady Cala?" Lady Ka unexpectedly joined the discussion. Lady Cala nodded sadly and said.

„You are indeed very well informed, Lady Ka. I regret to admit that you are right. She had a serious problem, but unfortunately I couldn't force her to do anything. After all, she had quite a difficult character. How did she fare on your quest, Lady of Blades?" The aristocrat smiled friendly at the knight.

„I can't say a single bad word about Miss Daisy. She was a great comrade in arms who saved my life." Asindesa said firmly. Everyone returned to less interesting topics again, although she noticed that there was now tension at the table. So she decided to make a toast. But first she helped herself to a portion of cabbage.

„I didn't know you liked pickles. You were always the, you know, sweets lover." Adora asked, looking at her with surprise.

„And I've been having cravings lately, which is a bit strange because I usually feel nauseous in the morning." she said, reaching for a mug of cider.

„I don't know if you should drink alcohol now." said Catra, looking at her in a very strange way.

„What do you mean?" She asked, completely not understanding what her friend was getting at.

„ What she means is that you shouldn't drink alcohol because you're pregnant. Don't worry you didn't tell us about it. I've known about it since yesterday, thanks to the bioscanner... But you knew you are pregnant, right?" Entrapta said with an innocent smile. There was absolute silence at the table . The first to interrupt it was the Lord Admiral.

Congratulations Queen Glimmer. I hope your offspring will be healthy, although you seem surprised that you are pregnant.

- No, I just... - she said somewhat unconsciously. She and Bow had been trying to have a baby together, but she never imagined it would happen so suddenly....

Bow hugged her tightly, and she touched her belly tenderly.

Like an idiotic romantic comedy, Calamity thought with disdain when she heard the big news, although she had to admit that the Lord Admiral had managed to get out of this absurd situation brilliantly. She had to admit that this man made a very good impression on her. He was one of the few mortals who commanded her respect. She felt strength in him, as unshakable as a rock facing a storm. He radiated the pride of someone who fully deserved it. He was not bound by the ordinary morality that shackled the rest of common people, but he was able to play by it, transforming it into both a weapon and a shield. How such a human could be a father of Spawn like Catra was beyond her understanding, but she had an idea that she might implement in the future, if it was the will of the Creeping Chaos!

"In what rite will your and Adora's wedding take place?" The Lord Admiral asked after a while.

"I think normally, under the moons, like everywhere on Etheri. Apparently on Eridani or Ikarus they invoke some kind of powerful beings, gods or something like that. It's such a local quirk of theirs. - Catra said, stroking the bizarre shape-shifting creature

behind her ear. She hadn't seen it before because it was invisible. Were animals allowed to have pets on this ridiculous planet?

„Gods are widely worshiped throughout the galaxy, and sometimes they return the favor, but usually they only wish to follow the ideals they embody. Our family has followed the teachings of Abbadar, Talavet and Lissala for centuries. But it's your wedding and it will take place according to your and your fiancée's desires.“ The Lord Admiral said and Glimmer answer in a confused voice.

„I thought these were just metaphors and myths, but you seem to take them seriously... Is your title, Hell Knight, also a reference to these matters to some extent?” the queen said to the Lady, who considered her answer, although Calamity knew well that the locals would not like any of her answers.

„Hell is a place that embodies tyranny, ruthless order at all costs. We, the Hellknights, are connected to Hell, not because we want to introduce its ideals to the mortal world, but because it is a lesser evil that we can use to fight a greater evil. However, each knight must be victorious in the fight against the devil from hell to prove that he is immune to corruption by dark forces.„ explained the knight of hell. Most of the crowd looked at her uncertainly, but after a moment Catra asked.

„Shadow Weaver once summoned a being that turned her into what she was. I recently found out that this being is called the Light Eater and is the Avatar of some Nyarlathotep or something... Is he one of those devils?”

Calamity almost burst into laughter filled with the sincerest joy when she saw the look on Asindesa Di Vir's face. It was so beautiful to see her just realize that the woman she was clearly in love with was a servant of the enemy she had sworn to fight against. She could actually taste her suffering... It was so delicious!

„No... „ The Lady of Blades began to speak in a dead, grave voice. “Nyarlathotep are something else. The Great Outer God, the Creeping Chaos, is an ancient being beyond mortal understanding. They are the Greater Evil against whom we swore to fight.”

No one except her fully understood what had happened, which only increased her joy. Finally the Lord Admiral said.

„I have a great request for you, Queen Glimmer, as well as for my daughter, because she is the Grand Marshal of your Army. In connection with the wedding, I would like to request that some of my soldiers and ships come here to ensure safety during this event.

All the Etherians' jaws dropped, and then Entrapta exclaimed happily.

„Of course we invite you, especially your ships!”

Glimmer looked at her in disbelief, then spoke firmly to Antares .

„We don't agree to this! In no case!”

Catra addressed the Lord Admiral in a much gentler voice.

„Lord... Father, understand, this planet has suffered a lot at the hands of those who invaded it from space. The sight of your troops can cause real panic.”

Antares looked at everyone with a serious voice and began to speak.

„I will speak bluntly. I have no doubt that you know how to wage war on your home planet, but you have no idea about war in space. I saw your fleet formation, or lack thereof. This wedding is the perfect opportunity to attack, you are unable to keep my daughter safe. Although Prime's heirs are not as formidable an enemy as, for example, the Swarm, they are still dangerous. And besides, if you are thinking about an alliance with us, and I'm sure

such a thought has crossed Queen Glimmer's mind, then our soldiers need to get to know each other in order to start cooperation.”

Glimmer wiped her forehead and said in a tired voice.

„Okay, I'll think about your proposal...”

Perfuma suddenly spoke up .

„What is the Swarm? There was tension and even fear in her voice.”

“The Swarm…” the Lord Admiral said thoughtfully. „This is the greatest plague of the Galaxy. A Hunger That Cannot Be Satiated. A living fleet guided by hive mind, traversing the universe to consume everything in its path. Fortunately, it is unlikely that it will come to this place.”

I would not be so sure. Calamity thought joylessly

In the shine of enchanted moons

Chapter Notes

Here is the next chapter. I would like to ask for your comments and opinions. What do you think about Nightgale?

After dinner, everyone prepared to return to their rooms, but first they all went out to the terrace to look at the stars. Everyone who wanted was brought a cup of mulled wine or hot chocolate, if they wanted it. The Queen cuddled up to her almost-husband, staring at the stars, lost in happy thoughts about the future. Nightgale would normally feel a pang of jealousy, her physiology was complicated and she never knew it well, Unfortunately no one could examine her because she didn't know anyone knowledgeable enough in the field that she could trust enough to reveal her true identity. Now she found this information very interesting and potentially troublesome for Lonnie, because the popularity of queens and princesses always increased when they were expecting children, and any attacks against them were met with a furious response from their subjects. This news completely changed the balance of power. Glimmer already had support in and around Brightmoon, and now support for the rebellion will completely disappeared. They don't actually do anything, but rather by doing something very pleasant, it has wiped out almost all their successes. If she didn't want to make things worse, Lonnie would have to rethink all her plans. But that was the least important news. The arrival of a war fleet from outside the empire completely changed the balance of power on the planet. She knew that Horde Prime's Empire had not conquered the entire universe, after all, the cultists were in contact with their master, who knew the truth... In its purest sense. But meeting people from there was something completely different. Meet those who did not know the fear of the mad tyrant, although as it turned out, they brought their own nightmares with them. The Lord Admiral was a formidable man, a true warrior, born to rule others, trained

from childhood to be a Leader, not an accidental warmaster like her… father. His army was not like Etheria 's . None of the princesses wanted war, and deep down Lonnie didn't want it either, and she certainly didn't want the kind of war this man could give them. Perhaps Comrade General should seriously consider signing an armistice or some other agreement, their greatest victory was not achieved thanks to military actions, but to political intrigues that were not even their work. The most important thing, however, was that Antares was Catra's father. For this reason alone, they should seriously consider again the goals they want to achieve. Until now, bringing justice to Catra had been one of the main demands of the People's Rebellion, at least for Lonnie, although everyone realized that the chances of its implementation were low, but now they have dropped to almost Zero. If Comrade General continues to pursue her personal vendetta, it could bring doom to them all. Although on the other hand, the fact that Catra is the daughter of a military leader outside Etheria with unclear and potentially hostile intentions towards their home could be used in their propaganda...

Catra has a father… It wasn't something either of them expected. Although she had heard some of Dr. Moors' recent hints about the Grand Marshal's origins, she had previously considered them of little importance... However, they turned out to be upending the balance of power on the planet. But was this news so important from the point of view of her true master? It was hard to say, anyway, as she looked at the Lord Admiral with a hint of a smile as he watched Catra, who was sipping hot chocolate with Adora, she felt the bitterness pulsating in her heart, for she was sure she would never experience anything like that.

The situation was different with the second guest who came to Brightmoon . Lady Cala seemed to be everything they had been promised, though now that she had finally arrived, she felt a strange uneasiness at seeing her feasting with Glimmer and the rest of the guests, who were completely unaware of her true, monstrous nature. She was just starting to realize what they had brought to Etheria and she wasn't sure she liked it. She felt something like remorse, but now it was far too late for any

doubts. She suspected that Lady Cala knew she was a servant of the Creeping Chaos by the way she looked at her. However, she was sure that she did not even remotely suspect who her parents were, and considering the way she spoke about Shadow Weaver, it was better for her not to find out the truth for now. Well, unlike most of Etheria's inhabitants, she knew it was not wise to risk the wrath of the gods, even the half-blood ones….

"Since you performed the ritual, I'm more and more concerned about being trapped on my small, backwater planet. You can't even imagine how boring it would be to spend centuries locked in my prison. Days after days, one like the other, and the only hope for freedom are those who found those damn mirrors. However, most of them disappoint me." said Aaravos, who was floating in the air with his hands under his head. He stayed elsewhere throughout the dinner, but when he returned, it turned out that he was perfectly informed about what had happened during his absence. Could he access her memory? It was a disturbing thought.

"Has my mother disappointed you too?" she asked in a sour tone. Aaravos thought for a long moment before giving her his answer.

"To some extent, yes, but not entirely. She performed the ritual as I wanted her to, but then she broke off all contact with me, and this could have cost us all a lot, as you have probably already guessed. If only she would renew our contact…. Everything could have turned out completely differently. However, you have to accept reality as it is. It's a pity that I still know so little about what really happened here... we all know too little, unfortunately, but maybe when I meet your Mother, I will get the answers I need, and the unnamed darkness knows how much I need them. My plots on Xadia turned out to be too successful, and even if I am released, without anyone's help, hundreds of years will have to pass before the inhabitants of my planet go to the stars, and that is definitely too long, especially if my creators want to return, and as we see, they have already taken some steps." he said, looking at Adora, who took a large sip and kissed Catra . "it's very strange to see another She-Ra. I didn't think they would try the

same idea twice, but if it's a good idea, why not try it again...” Saihe wondered strangely.

“Have you met Mara?” she asked quietly with curiosity

“Mara ? No, we haven't met, I haven't talked to the previous real She-Ra either, although due to a certain... project in which I participated, I know quite a lot about her.”

She blinked several times in surprise.

“The previous real She-Ra? What do you mean?” she asked curiously. The love of secrets was in her blood. Aaravos laughed, and there was so much evil and wickedness in that laugh that she felt her soul tingle.

“Sweet child of spring. You don't know so much about the history of your planet... In its own way, it says a lot about the memory of mortal beings.” he said thoughtfully. She was about to ask him to explain what he meant, but then she heard a beautiful, resonant voice behind her.

“Hi... Your name is Nightgale, right? I cannot devote too much time to you so as not to attract the attention of nosy and uninitiated people. Let me just say that I am very pleased to meet someone who serves such noble lords... or has such great friends.” Lady Cala said, smiling serenely at her and slightly bowing to Aaravos. She felt a strange twinge of jealousy when she saw the saihe sorcerer respond to the woman with a polite bow. Until now, she believed that she was the only person who could see him. Now it turns out that she is not the only one. But on the other hand, could she blame such a creature for knowing her secrets? Her father know everything after all. She also bowed to her and spoke softly.

“It's a real honor for me to meet you. We've been waiting for you for so long.”

The creature hiding behind the face of the beautiful girl leaned towards her and whispered almost tenderly into her ear.

“I know you're something different than you seem, but I'm not sure who yet. But I can't wait to get to know you more personally.” she said and kissed her on the cheek.

“It was a very busy day, considering that we were officially just relaxing.” said Lady Ka to the Lord Admiral, who was drinking his second cup of mulled wine. Usually, her commander avoided alcohol, but this time he indulged a little. He was very pleased, because it must be admitted that his entire stay there turned out to be a great success. He made the right impression on the people of Etheria and, most importantly, on his daughter. They still didn't trust him, of course, the locals weren't as idiots as they seemed, but that was to be expected. It was only a matter of time to gain their favor. They had too many common enemies, and nothing united sentient beings like a common enemy. Although who is whose enemy remains to be seen.

Politics is an activity that requires constant vigilance, because every gesture, every look is a weapon and a shield. It is like a theater, but unlike the pathetic fools that fill Parliaments or councils, a true statesman knows that he can never afford to step out of character, while never forgetting that it is all just a game.” Antares said in the Vesk language, which certainly none of the locals understood.

“It must be admitted that this Shadow Weaver helped you a lot in implementing your plans, although probably unknowingly, unless she is a smarter bitch than we think.” she said, glancing at the Hell Knight

“Doubtful. From what my daughter told me about her, she was intelligent and skilled in dark magic, but she was very easy to give in to impulses and petty desires. Such people are usually not able to plan such complex intrigues... And besides, she had no right to know that whatever was connected between me and her former ward, she probably doesn't guess the truth even now.” Antares

explained with a hint of contempt in his voice. Was it on purpose or was the wine speaking through him?

“I'm more and more curious about what happened on Carurystal that made our noble knight more gloomy than usual. Were they very… close friends? Such a weakness for a Hellknight...” Lady Ka had a hard time keeping herself from giggling.

“Everyone has the right to weakness, and love for the wrong person is one of the most difficult to resist. The fact that we sometimes give in to them is not a problem, it is worse when they start to rule our lives.” said her commander seriously.

“Only when you succumb to your weakness, hundreds of thousands die,” thought Lady Ka, but she knew that it would be unwise to say such words.

“Why didn't you tell them about the Starstone... Lady Cala or even that stupid knight could blurt out about it at any time.” she finally asked.

“Lady Cala is not stupid, and I don't think she would want to go against us. She very skillfully confirmed her mentor's identity, while distancing herself from her. Asindesa cannot reveal much, and due to her connections with the dark sorceress, she is not very credible in the eyes of the inhabitants of this planet. Even if one of them revealed the truth about the Artifact, well, better them than me. Given the direction our conversation has taken today, I might come across as greedy.

Lady Ka wasn't sure she liked her boss's reasoning. Before she could say anything, Lady Cala walked up to the queen, who was beaming with sily joy, and said.

“I have an item in my possessions that Mara's daughter took with her to Carurystal. It is a certain stone, similar to the one my ring is made of.” she showed her ring with a red stone interspersed with green metallic veins. “Apparently it's a runestone or

something. I would like to give it away, or rather return it to its rightful owners as a wedding gift.”

“Well, thank you very much for your gift.” said the Queen in a gentle voice. The purple-haired idiot looked up and shouted with uncontrollable enthusiasm.

“Runestone! Can I see him? These are incredibly valuable artifacts that made you able...” she didn't finish because Lady Cala interrupted her by speaking in a gentle, soothing voice.

“Unfortunately, I left them at the place where I was staying, but I promise that as soon as I bring them here, you will be able to examine them. However, I have one extremely important question of a legal nature.” the beautiful aristocrat said to the queen, who broke out of her sweet daze and looked at Lady Cala with concern.

“Yes? What's the question?”

“Maybe some of you here don't know yet, but on Icarus we met your mother, Queen Angela . In fact, I traveled with her for some time. However, since your mother is alive, was your coronation Legal and, therefore, does any document you have signed since then have legal power?” the aristocrat spoke in an absolutely innocent voice. “You don't have to answer me now, I just wanted to draw your attention to this fact.” Glimmer bowed helpfully and headed towards her chambers. As she passed them, she gave them a soft, friendly smile. "So we have an unexpected ally," the clone woman thought.

He felt an burst of power and left the hut. He returned to her after his conversation with Shadow Weaver to reflect on everything he had learned. His wife is alive, and so is the woman who destroyed his life. He was able to accept that the dark sorceress was alive, but he still didn't want revenge on her, at least not enough for her to blind him. What was important now

was saving Angela, everything else was secondary. But how was he supposed to do it? Especially alone? Shadow Weaver promised to help him afterward, but could he trust her? However, he had no one to ask for help. He couldn't tell Glimmer because the chances of saving Angela were slim, and he couldn't let his daughter go through the Pain of losing her mother again. He couldn't tell Glimmer about it either because of the Shadow Weaver, but even if Glimmer hadn't immediately started teleporting around the planet, alerting everyone to the Dark Sorceress's presence, she would have told Catra everything, and the cat girl's anger which still burn brightly and it could cause old wounds to reopen. Likewise, he couldn't tell any other member of the alliance, because either they herself wouldn't keep a secret from Catra, or their spouse wouldn't. The exceptions were Netossa and Spinnerella, and Huntara, although he didn't know how the latter could help them. However, he could count on Castaspella and Lance and George the most, because none of them would act rashly... For a moment he thought about telling the others about this other girl so similar to Catra and about the Heart Gift., but he decided that it could lead to this anyway that Shadow Weaver is alive, even this AI could make some comment that would reveal too much. No, for now he had to stay silent, although it was hard for him to describe how difficult it was. So he sighed heavily and with great effort put on the cheerful mask that parents so often had to put on for their children, and then went outside to greet Glimmer.

His daughter stared at the starry sky. She looked dreamy, although she looked exhausted. She turned to him, smiling tenderly.

“Do you often stare at the stars, wondering what they might be hiding?” she asked. He looked up for a moment and said.

“Often, both during the day and at night. You see, on Beast Island I haven't seen an open sky for so many years. At first it even made me anxious, but then there was a war and I couldn't afford to be afraid... And now I like looking at it because it reminds me that I am finally free.| he said, and then Glimmer sighed and

became sad, so he asked her. - Did something happen. She hesitated before answering, which only confirmed his fears. She then told him that a Lord Admiral had come to Etheria, bringing his own fleet with him, and that he was Catra's father. He fell silent, wondering how much of this Shadow Weaver knew. She had this other girl with her. She implied that she and Catra were sisters. Did the Admiral know about this too? It wouldn't surprise him if she kept it from him. Even as a Light Spinner, she loved mysteries and secrets.

“How is Catra?” he asked, thinking about his feline friend.

- She's confused, like all of us. Oh daddy, do you want me to take you to Brightmoon ? – she asked shyly. He hesitated because he knew that Glimmer was definitely counting on his support, but on the other hand he couldn't imagine how he could look his Daughter and Catra in the eye while hiding such great secrets.

“Unfortunately, I can't. I'm still looking for information about Umbracor. On my last trip, I found more questions than answers.”

Glimmer nodded thoughtfully and said.

“When you come to the wedding, I have great news for you, but for now, dad, I have to go back. – she disappeared in a flash of Magic.

"I may have some wonderful news for you too, if I can" he thought and went back to the cottage to look through "The History of the Sorcerer's War" at the top of the page was written "The Secret of Kranor Rill"

Doctor Sidonius silently landed on the ground and assumed his true form. He decided that there was no point in hiding his talent on this planet, since they had already learned that the locals knew surprisingly little about vampires and the undead. On the other hand, the only person present was Archduke Kane Adamson, who was sitting on a bench and looking at the mural painted on the

ornate wall. Previously, he was finished off by a nice deaf artist. She became friends with his daughter, despite her disability. He approached the mural that depicted the history of the last months of the war. He looked at the image of a tall winged woman.

“Well, so you were the queen... Who would have thought.” said the ancient vampire with a smile showing both fangs. Kane looked at him with his blue eyes, glowing in the dark. Most mortals trembled under that gaze, but he was used to ancient terror… And he wasn't a mortal.

“After all these millennia, you should have noticed long ago that we encounter extraordinary people very often.” said a man with hair as red as blood in a thoughtful voice. He had been in a reflective mood since they arrived on this planet. As far as he knew him, the Archduke of Carurystal had a tendency towards melancholy, which contrasted with the brutal, almost barbaric impression he had on others.

“If you say so.” he said and touched the mural with his fingertips, but then Kane Adamson added.

“Or maybe this is just our impression, because due to our existence lasting eons, we simply remember only extraordinary and unique people, and we forget about the countless masses of ordinary mortals who are dubiously lucky to cross our path.”

Dr. Sidonius snorted in irritation

- You're starting to talk like an Elf.

“No, probably the Elves are ones who talk like me.” Kane said and walked up to the mural, looking at it thoughtfully. Dr. Sidonius looked at the image of the cat girl kissing She- Ra .

“When I told everyone that the girl survived, no one believed me, but here you go, look how high she has reached.” he said, beaming with joy.

“It's not your fault, Doctor. It's probably due to fate, which, as we both know, is a nasty bitch.” The Archduke of Carurystal touched Horde Prime's likeness just before She-Ra destroyed him.

“I remember a certain man, his name was Galtea the Avenger. He claimed to be a hero fighting evil, but he was a fucker even worse than me, that's quite an achievement. He didn't really accomplish much, he wanted to hunt me down before his career took off, and I'm probably the only one who remembers his existence, but... He was the first being to talk about the cold, cleansing light. Then I heard similar words many times. They were always invoked by exceptional Bastards. Horde Prime was similar to them, although admittedly much more powerful.” said the Archduke of Carurystal. Dr. Sidonius shrugged.

“There are a finite number of ideas, and with the scale of the universe, it's only a matter of time until someone comes up with the same idea again.”

“Maybe... You know, I was here. I don't know when or why, but I remember being there.”

The Doctor looked sideways at his companion.

“And what were you doing? – he asked suspiciously.

“I'm not sure, but I think there's something very bad, even for me... I have to look for something here, something I lost. I'll leave you for a while. I'm sure you'll be fine without me.” he said and set off on his way, illuminated by the glow of the enchanted moons.

A heated argument

Chapter Notes

And here's the next chapter. Please leave your comments and opinions

Itel was finally started to like it here. This place, the headquarters of the People's Rebellion, Castle Crypto or whatever it was called, made a good impression. Order and discipline reigned here. During the last two days, she had seen the members of the Rebellion training, repairing equipment, as well as talking, having fun, in short, they do exactly what she do with her friends, but somehow better. More neatly. She didn't know much about the military, after all, her only exposure to it was her time among the Shadows of Tarak, but they seemed quite competent. She was even starting to wonder if they could somehow support them in their fight. They had a large arsenal of quite good weapons and were well trained. Many of them were cadets, orphans trained from childhood to fight for Wrongdak’s Brother. Now they fought against the queen, the same one who had been stunned by Rosie and then kidnapped Eti. Now she was hosting the thousand times cursed Antares. Perhaps she could somehow use this to talk her into fighting the Admiral, but there was a problem. Everyone here avoided them as much as they could. Yes, they were polite and polite, but they kept their distance. It even seemed that they were afraid of them. They had many reasons for this.

For most of them, the existence of other planets was something new, and the fact that civilisations completely unfamiliar with this Horde Prime had survived and thrived beyond the Empire was difficult to imagine. They were the first people from their part of galaktyki that they encountered, she was aware that their group could cause anxiety among normal people, and from what she

had managed to notice, the Rebels were definitely less trusting and friendly than the inhabitants of Brightmoon, at least towards strangers. This was probably partly due to Wrongdak's presence, most of the Rebellion members once belonged to the Horde, which was ruled by his Brother, and they were probably not too proud of that. They transferred their dislike for their former leader to Wrongdak and the remaining clones...

However, these were not the most important reasons for the distrust and fear they aroused. She guessed the others. First of all, Eti's sister was their friend, their comrade in arms with whom they grew up together... And she must have been very... mean to the others, to put it mildly. She knew Eti, and although she loved her like no one else in the world, she was aware that relationships with her could be... difficult. And Catra seems to have become the leader's second in command, his right hand. She knew Igzar and knew well how ruthless a leader he could be, much like the Lord Admiral. Subjugating others may have been in her genes. But perhaps they were most distrusted because of Miss Daisy, or rather Shadow Weaver, which was her real name, quite an apt choice, she had to admit. She was the one who supervised the cadets and raised Eti's sister and her fiancée... She understood that much, but there had to be something more to it. What had this old alcoholic done that she was treated here like a bogeyman, a demon to be feared and not allowed to approach anything he had a connection with lest he become corrupted. She knew the woman was a powerful sorceress skilled in dark magic, but nothing more. Why should anyone be afraid of her? Apparently they didn't know what true terror was, they hadn't experienced what they had, they hadn't encountered the Swarm.

But eventually she had to talk to someone, if only to pass the time. She saw a stocky, slightly gray-haired Bugbear watching with a sour face as the Rebels unloaded fruit from the truck. Bugbear shouldn't be afraid, right?

„Hello, I'm Itel." she stretched out her hand, smiling. Unfortunately, in contacts with other people she was only good compared to Eti, especially when she tried to be nice. Maybe she

should ask Rosie for help? Everyone liked her. Bugbear didn't shake her hand, but looked at her with a little interest.

„They call me Grizzol , and I'm the Storm Captain here. What do you want from me?” he asked in a hoarse voice.

„I've never seen Bugbear before , even though I've traveled a lot around the galaxy.” she said and cursed in her mind, because this was not the best way to start a conversation. She really should have asked Rosie for help. Grizzol, however, looked at her curiously.

„I have never heard anyone from outside our people use this word.” he muttered.

„And there are many of you here... Bugbears ... On Etheri.” she continued the conversation, sticking to this topic, because it seemed to have a good effect.

„Not many now, although we were never many, but during the war lot of us died fighting for both sides. Now there are maybe a thousand of us left and most of those who survived live in scattered groups... Although if you say that we can be found on other planets... But I have not survived over twenty years of war without developing the ability to read between the lines. So tell me what you really want from me, okay?”

She hesitated before asking.

„It's about my friend. Eti, the cat-like one. Why is everyone here reacting so strangely to her... I know she reminds you of someone you know, but you all act like she's about to do something terrifing.” she didn't add that most of those who got to know Eti better also expected her to do something terrifying soon.

„She doesn't look like her, she just looks like she's her sister…„ Bugbear growled , and she interrupted him, grinning and trying to smile friendly.

„Because actually, they are sisters.”

She thought she's the first person in the galaxy to have managed to render a Bugbear speechless.

„Who the fuck is she... Never mind, I don't think I want to know if there are even more Catras in the world, one was too many. You see, Catra was one of the cadets. She has always been a cunning girl, willing to win at all costs, no matter how she can hurt everyone. I really shouldn't blame her, we were all more ruthless back then than we are today, and she was, after all, Hordak's right-hand protégé ... She had harder life than most, I admit, but when she took Shadow Weaver's place... she became even worse. She was willing to do anything to win, she forced us to do terrible things when we opposed her, she threatened to tear us apart or condemn us to a fate worse than death, which she did to her friend, and in the end, it was because of her the Prime's Horde came . I don't know if your Eti is like her, but everyone prefers to assume that she is. So don't be surprised that we all remain reserved, because that's what life in the Horde and over twenty-five years of war have taught us, and you also brought Shadow Weaver here.

„Exactly. Miss Daisy…Shadow Weaver. I know she's a powerful mystic and all, but basically she's just a conceited old drunk and you're acting like she's fucking Glabrezu.”

Grizzol looked around fearfully, then swear.

„Damn it, it's starting again! You see! Because of this hag, we lived in fear for twenty-five years. Almost everyone on the planet hates her and was very happy that she was dead”

Itel blinked twice.

„How is she dead? From what I saw, she's quite alive. He gets drunk, goes to the toilet... The undead don't do that.” she said, although honestly she had no idea whether Doctor Sidonius was using the toilet… This is not a topic that normal people think about. „ I know a somethingabout the undead, I even destroyed some!”

Bugbear looked at her for a moment before speaking.

„Catra and Adora told everyone that and I have no reason not to believe them. Adora can't lie, and Catra wouldn't lie for her. Not after everything she had done to her.” for a moment she saw something like sympathy in bugbear's pale eyes. She felt a little disconcerted and even a little worried.

„What do you mean? What did she do to her? What she did to all of you.”

Grizzol became a bit suspicious . He laughed darkly and said.

„It's best if she tells you herself. She's a lying bitch, she can't deny that. Maybe she faked her own death, though I don't know how she escaped with Etheri where you found her... And my advice to you is to stay away from her, or at least don't trust anything she says.”

She smiled sourly at the Bugbear

„Do not worry about me. I don't trust anyone.... Almost no one.”

She was thirsty, she was fucking thirsty. She would give a lot to have a drink... although one word would probably be enough for her to get alcohol. She saw here the former subordinates from the technical department, who were probably making their old product, although they probably improved the recipe to get rid of the disgusting taste, although it didn't bother her, the only thing that mattered was how quickly she could get drunk on it... Yes, no one would refuse to give her moonshine… Probably as much as anything else. She suspected that even if she wanted to take over, she wouldn't encounter much resistance. A simple show of power would be enough to force her former subordinates into submission. But it wasn't something she wanted. And what exactly did she want? She wasn't sure... She looked at her clawed hands. They were shaking from alcohol withdrawal. It was harder for her to concentrate now, even though she knew that if she started

drinking now, she would fall into a bloody drunken spree... She had to resist this temptation, although to be honest, this whole place was one big temptation.

"So this is what it's like to be in the Abyss…" she said darkly, but Ireanis looked at her, smiling crookedly.

„No... This place doesn't resemble the Abyss at all. I know because I've been there several times. The longest time was when we had to bring back some student who summoned a succubus because he wanted to fuck... Well, that actually happens quite often, I mean summoning succubi, not kidnapping students or traveling to the abyss, but I get what you mean. I am thirsty too. Thirsty as hell.„ sighed the sorceress from Lost Golarion. She smiled at her. When she served in the Horde, she preferred to stay alone most of the time, plotting her intrigues and conducting experiments, usually more or less unsuccessful. Once, one almost killed her... If it weren't for Catra finding her unconscious on the floor, she would probably have faced the Creeping Chaos much earlier. Of course, she returned the favor by yelling at Catra, furious that the girl saw her in a moment of weakness. Now she was happy with Ireanis' presence, thanks to the Elf it was easier for her to endure both the rehab and the waiting. Lonnie gave her and Ireanis a room, asked to share a room with two separate beds, but hasn't called her since. The room was comfortable, located among the outer buildings of the castle, where servants and officers probably lived in oldtimes. It was spacious, but so short that her head hit the ceiling; the inhabitants of Castle Crypto were not known for their height. It was always cloudy around the castle, and the windows were narrow, so it was dim. It didn't bother her, what was much worse was waiting to talk to Comrade General. She guessed that Lonnie wanted to soften her up by making her wait, and also to prepare for the interview with his former teacher. These weren't bad tactics, but they didn't have time for such games now, they had to come up with a plan as soon as possible to counter the Lord Admiral before it was too late!

Lonnie… She didn't know this girl well, at least not as well as she should have, as proven by the fact that she had to rely on her for help. She remembered that the current Comrade General was Adora's friend, but she couldn't stand Catra. She was always the third best cadet, even though Catra and Adora were several levels more capable than her. Although she apparently didn't even appreciate it, she eventually became the leader of her own rebellion and even took over Entrapta's castle, although it wasn't really a great achievement. She organized her former comrades in arms and gave them a new purpose, making them a military force to be reckoned with. *As they say in the Pact Worlds, once you let a Genie out of the bottle you can't put it back in.*

Finally she heard footsteps and the door to her room opened. There stood a small person who was probably not even eighteen years old when the war ended.

„Comrade General Lonnie is calling you to his quarters.” it said, trying not to let its voice crack.

„You've grown up, Sune. Okay, take me to your leader. Ireanis, if any of my wards ask, tell them where I went. – she said and followed Sune

Itel looked for her friends. She found them by the fire, roasting marshmallows. Or rather, she found Rosie, Lilka and Alatar. Eti could be absolutely anywhere, and she would be here as soon as she smelled meat sizzling on the fire. Their ship landed nearby. They had even made a makeshift landing pad for him, and now Mr. Ilemshaw 's drones were floating above their heads. They lived on a ship, although they were also offered shelter in the castle, or rather its outer part. As far as she could tell, everyone was avoiding going inside the castle. As she approached, Rosie stood up and waved at her.

„Hi! Eti said she was going to look for Kyle and would be back in time for dinner.” she said in sign language

„Kyle?” she asked, wondering who the deaf girl was talking about.

„You know, the tall blond one. He was nice to us. I guess that's why Eti wants to talk to him.” Rosie replied. She nodded, she remembered him now. He was nice and quite handsome.

„Okay, where are Wrongdak and Emily?” she asked, and Alatar pointed behind him. The clone was cleaning the inside of the ship, more for the sake of something to do than out of any real need. Then Dragonkin asked a question himself

„Did you learn anything new?”

He grimaced before she answered him

„Nothing specific. They told me a little about Eti’s sister and Miss Daisy's past, although I don't know what to think about it. This Catra has a lot of Eti in her, but more of their father. And what they said about Miss Daisy... I can't believe this drunkard could be someone everyone here is afraid of. If there is any truth in this, she must have fallen very low.”

When she said this, she was given her own stick with marshmallows, and Alatar started stiking sausages and local bread onto other sticks. They stared into the fire for a moment until Rosie finally spoke carefully.

„You know, if I had known earlier that the Lord Admiral was evil and you didn't like him, I would have told you about him earlier.”

Everyone froze and looked at the white-haired girl.

„So you knew about him before…” she asked slowly in a very quiet and seemingly calm voice, and Rosie blushed and looked down guiltily.

„Because our expedition was related to the fleet from the beginning. That's what the others said. Dilayla, Arkan-tar, Miss Daisy, but they forbade me to mention it to anyone. I would tell you everything anyway if...”

She didn't let her finish. Feeling rage flooding through her, she summoned her moonblade and leapt at the girl.

„You false, traitorous bitch! You planned it all from the beginning!” she screamed, putting the blade to her throat. Rosie tried to back away and started waving her arms.

„Silence, you crippled whore!” she said and ripped her glasses off her face, and then, to the white-haired girl's horror, crushed them with her shoe with cold satisfaction.

„Listen, Itel. I think you're exaggerating a bit... maybe you could sit down and calm down?” Alatar said carefully, but she ignored him. He's always been a wimp. She smiled predatorily and said.

„ Now you will pay for everything.” and she jumped at the girl, taking a swing. She didn't actually mean to kill her, just to tear her face open or take out one of her blue eyes. She won't be so fake cute anymore. But before she could strike, Rosie grabbed her hand and looked at her. Her eyes glowed white.

She liked it when others were afraid of her. She felt safe then, aware of how dangerous she was. If you were dangerous, no one could do anything to you. But she didn't want to be scary all the time. It made her feel guilty, like she was someone evil who should be feared, one who thought hurting others was just fun... she wasn't a monster, certainly not that bad anyway, and she didn't and she didn't want others to see her as one. Moreover, it was not her fear, but inherited from the other one. From that Catra. She didn't know why they were so afraid of her, but she would find out. That's why she was looking for this blond guy. He will definitely explain everything to her. He was her sister's friend after all... He certainly knew a lot about her. And besides, she liked him. He was afraid of everything, but he had courage in his heart, even if he fainted at the sight of Miss Daisy.

She found the blonde in the tool shed. It wasn't too difficult, the boy had a very specific scent around him. Now he was crouching down in thought and staring at this strange sword.

„Hey Blond Boy was she scary?" she asked, approaching him from behind. At the sound of her voice, he jumped and screamed softly, then turned towards her, his hand on the hilt of his sword.

„Ah, it's just you... Do you have to be sneaky like that?" he asked with a trembling voice.

Just You! she thought indignantly and replied.

„Of course I could, why wouldn't I be able to, but why would I want to, and besides, a question isn't answered with a question. Haven't you in this Horde learned basic social skills?"

He looked at her with a mixture of confusion and disorientation, others often looked at her this way, and said in a very uncertain voice.

„I don't know who you mean… Shadow Weaver or Catra …"

„Well, of course my sister, because why would anyone in their right mind be afraid of Grimm? Sure, she knows some dark magic, but she's basically alright. She saved me and Sparkle Paw's skin several times, and you look at her as if she was electrocuting you for your insubordination..." she said, and he looked at her that way again.

„Because she did it, often... Especially to Catra... That and other, worse things. That's why Catra became the way she became. She was a bit like you and Shadow Weaver... Dangerous, ruthless, cunning, terrifying...„ He didn't finish because Eti interrupted him.

„Yes, those are my traits, but how was she similar to Shadow Weaver?" she asked, tilting her head on her shoulder. Kyle took a deep breath as if to say something, but then stopped and stared at her hand. She rolled up her sleeve and put it under his nose.

„Cool, isn't it? I had her when she woke up one day... I don't know exactly where she's from, I'm not sure, but it was after a fight where... Never mind, it can shock people with electricity , open locks and has these funny inscriptions...

„I know, I see them... „ the Blondie Boy blurted out.

„But only I can see them.” she finished and started looking at him. “Can you read them?” she asked curiously. She guesses Rechiza could read them too, or at least that's what she claimed.

„Well, yes, but... „ he was as pale as a corpse, she felt like she was going to faint again. Just don't tell anyone about it because… Just don't tell anyone…”

The thought began to form in her mind that she probably knew why the boy didn't want anyone to know that he could read the First Ones' language. But there was one more thing she had to find out.

„Okay, but tell me what it says, because I can't read that.”

The blonde nodded and began to look at her hand with concentration and then slowly read it.

„This is the Punishing Hand, created to avenge... And this is where the writing ends, I'm sorry... he looked at her apologetically, so she patted him on the shoulder. He smiled at her and seemed to want to ask her something, but then Itel screamed.

She wiped her forehead and looked at Shadow Weaver sitting in a chair, drinking tea. She shuddered. She hasn't gotten used to looking at her face yet. She should have known from the beginning that the arrival of that damned witch would not portend anything good, but not that it would be something so terrible.

„Did this guy, this Antares, come here with his fleet?” she asked, feeling her head starting to hurt more and more.

„I told you, I have no idea. I only saw a fragment of the conversation between the Lord Admiral and Glimmer. I don't know more than that, although our sensors didn't detect anything, but that was two days ago. Besides, I don't know if his ships have any jamming systems." she said in an irritated voice. With some effort, she stopped herself from cringing. All these years they had been afraid of her wrath, even the slightest anger. He won't let her do that to them again. Never again!

„Is he really such a monster as you say? And why should I believe all this? You've been feeding us lies for so many years, so how do I know you're not doing it again?"

The dark sorceress smiled sadly and spoke in a gloomy and very tired voice.

„You have no reason to trust me, I have earned your suspicion. But you don't have to ask me, ask those kids, they'll repeat everything I told you."

„You're talking about Catra's sister and the rest." she asked, frowning. The thought of damned Catra having a sister wandering freely around her castle was downright painfully frustrating. She didn't know what she should do now, she agreed to take it because she needed Shadow Weaver, but she didn't like the fact that her Catra amount had doubled. Truth be told, the girl wasn't that bad, she didn't get in her way, she just wandered around the castle. But after all, she was the sister of the Grand Marshal, and if what Hordak's old Right Hand said about the cat girls' father was true, then this whole damned family was corrupted through and through. She was very happy with the new alliances she had made, despite her earlier doubts.

„But what do you think we should do?" she asked the dark sorceress, who hesitated before answering.

„I had already taken some steps, although at that time I didn't know that the Lord Admiral would arrive here so soon, or that he

was Catra's father…." she didn't finish because there were shrieks outside .

Itel tried to pull her hand from Rosie's grip, but she couldn't. The girl was unnaturally strong. So she kicked her in the chin as hard as she could, but it didn't help. The deaf girl clenched her hand and her bones broke. She screamed softly, luckily, she had high pain toleration, but she had to unsummon the blade, which she then had summoned in her other hand. From behind, Lilka tried to pull her back, but she was kicked hard and fell backwards for several minutes, but thanks to this she managed to pull her arm away, although the wrist was still broken. She attacked Rosie several times but the girl dodged them all without any problems, then she jumped high into the air and fell to the ground, dealing a terrible blow with her fist. She jumped away at the last moment, but the impact was so powerful that the ground shook and the elf fell over. She rolled under the truck, but Rosie jumped over to her and lifted the truck, then threw it aside. Where does this strength come from? The former intern was radiant with bright light, and her eyes were as uniformly white as a blind man's, although the brightest light emanated from them. The white-haired girl's face expressed absolute concentration, but otherwise she did not express any emotions. She lunged towards Itel, intending to strike a blow that would probably shatter her skull. But then black tentacles shot out towards the girl's arms and immobilized her. It didn't take long for them to suddenly break apart as the light coming from Rosie pulsated, but it gave the elf a moment to get back on her feet. She wasn't going to run away, even though she knew she couldn't defeat the deaf girl. It was a very stupid death, but she probably asked for it. Several rebel members tried to surround the girl, but she waved her hand and blasted them away with a wave of bright light. She was getting ready to receive the final blow, but then Eti appeared behind Rosie and placed a metal hand on her shoulder. Then the glow faded and Rosie's eyes went back to normal. The girl began to look around confused and scared. She tried to say something, but apparently she had damaged her gloves during the fight and no one understood her...

Except Eti... The cat girl said something reassuring in Sign Language, and Alatar began to talk about what happened. At first she felt a surge of anger towards the dragonkin, but the longer she listened to his words, the more she realized that she had gone too far. Eti hugged Rosie, who started sob spasmodically, and then she said.

„Listen, Itel. I know how you feel about me, and I love you too, but not like this... I can be your friend, sometimes I can even make love to you, but nothing more... Because you do things like this."

Tears began to run down Solarian's face. She realised that what Eti had said was final. That it was forever over between them.

„She knew that the entire expedition was organized by Antares and she didn't tell us anything, and she considers herself our friend! If it weren't for the Shadows of Tarak, we would all be lost!"

Alatar and Lilka looked at her with horror

„What have you done... „ said the shocked Dragonkin. Eti just said quietly.

„It's easy to see a hero in a villain..."

„Who are the Shadows of Tarak?" asked Lonnie, who had just arrived.

„The biggest bunch of bastards you can imagine." Dragonkin whispered.

Fall of Kesler - Burning Sky

Chapter Notes

> Here's another chapter of my fan fic, probably the darkest of all. The hive creatures described here are the Vorphoma and the Dredger. Please give me feedback and comments

Itel tried not to be as quiet as possible. She barely dared to take a deep breath. She hadn't seen anything dangerous yet, but the forest was so quiet that the pounding of her heart seemed as loud as thunder. She was scared. For the first time in her life, she was truly scared. She hadn't heard much about the Swarm until now, and even when they started talking about it approaching their planet, she had never truly believed that she would ever have to face it, or rather flee from it. But she didn't know where. On the banks of the river, a several hours' rowboat ride away, was the town of Ulm, where she hoped to meet her family...

Her family… She hoped they were safe… That they had all managed to escape. She forgot the anger she felt towards them, now she just wanted nothing to happen to them. She prayed silently to all the gods for it. Her plans to become a soldier were dashed. Real soldiers aren't so afraid that they pee under themselves, she barely had the courage to lower her pants. She had no idea how long she had been swimming, judging by the position of the sun it must have been only a few hours, but it was impossible. She was sure it had been a whole day or more. Her blood father had left a surprising amount of supplies here for her, clearly he had been preparing for the possibility of escape for some time. Was he planning for the two of them to escape together, leaving the rest of their settlement behind to the mercy of the Swarm? She wasn't sure she wanted to know the answer to that question.

While she was lost in these dark thoughts, she heard a loud buzzing noise. She immediately stuck to the bottom of the boat, not caring that it was wet with urine. Before, she only rowed when she had to avoid a rock or a shallow spot, afraid to make any noise, but now she stayed still, letting the boat drift. Nothing happened for a moment, so she lifted her head to look around and that's when she saw it. The creature was in the tree and she felt like it was watching her. How intelligent were the Swarm creatures? This monster was quite large, larger than her anyway, and had wings like a locust and somewhat resembled a Shirren, many members of this species lived on Kesler. However, this one had larger mandibles and front limbs equipped with long chitin claws capable of tearing it to pieces. She didn't move, hoping that the monster, like many predators, was mainly capable of perceiving movement, but then he looked in her direction and she realized that he saw her. Power flared around his antennae. She felt an overwhelming fear, so great that what she had experienced so far was only ordinary anxiety. She wanted to escape, to run as fast as she could, away from this monster. However, she realized what had happened, the creature had cast a spell on her that caused terror. She managed to fend him off, she didn't know if she would have been able to do it if it weren't for the fact that she was on a boat, because she would have had to jump into the river to escape. However, the monster saw that his spell did not work and jumped towards her with a loud hiss. He pinned her to the bottom of the boat and tried to crush her head with his mandibles, but she stuffed the gun her father had given her into her mouth and pulled the trigger. A beam of light shot from the gun and exited from the other side of the head. The creature fell in an instant, but it clamped its mandibles spasmodically on her weapon and slid into the river. She wanted to jump after him, but the corpse sank along with her weapon. She stared at the water for a few moments, breathing heavily, and then she felt the fear melt away... She wasn't afraid anymore, not like before. Instead, she felt a sudden surge of determination. She had to survive, at all costs, even if her only weapon was a knife. She grabbed the oars and started rowing.

He shuffled one foot at a time, passing cars stuck in traffic jams. Most of their owners stayed there, not wanting to abandon their belongings. Alatar didn't care. He didn't care about anything anymore. He lost his sister, whom he promised to take care of. He lost all his camp mates, his means of transport, everything. He was left alone in the middle of the Swarm invasion. He had no idea what to do now or where to go, so he just trudged forward, one foot at a time.

Flashes and flames still lit up the sky, although less intense than before. He didn't know if that was good or bad, and honestly, he didn't care anymore. He didn't care about anything. He felt almost no pain in his feet, in fact he felt almost nothing. Some tried to call out to him, others even tried to stop him. He didn't understand what they wanted from him or what they were saying to him. Whether they wanted to help him or expected him to help them, he didn't know and he didn't care. However, no one bothered him, after all, he was a Dragonkin and he was bigger than everyone else in every way and he breathed fire, no normal person would try to stand in front of a dragon, even such a small one.

Finally he reached the river. He only noticed it when he was waist-deep in water. The bridge was blocked by cars, a truck was standing across it and turned on its side. The coolness of the water and the smell of mud sobered him up a bit, and he began to wonder what to do next. He should consider how to get to the other side and then look for the nearest town. He saw an elf in a boat, rowing furiously. He looked behind her and thought for a moment, then entered the water, took the datapad into his mouth, and lay on his back. He was a good swimmer, great at swimming on his back, and decided to swim downstream. It will swim somewhere. What next, he didn't know.

She cried all the way, hugging Mr. Tut. She wanted to go home, but she knew it was impossible. She wasn't stupid. She knew her home was gone. Dad and mom... she couldn't even say the word in her head. She could only drive away crying. She was shaking terribly and everything hurt, but they didn't stop, only once to pee, even though she almost didn't want to. She didn't drink anything, they didn't even think about eating anymore. They were taking side roads because apparently the roads were blocked or something. They hadn't seen any other bugs so far, but she was afraid that they would get them. She was even afraid to look out the window because they could be lurking everywhere to catch them and devour them. She saw flames in the sky. Sometimes they managed to pick up a radio signal and then heard them say that the fleet was still fighting and had shot down hundreds of enemy ships. Mr. Tut said that the sky was burning because they were enemy ships exploding and they are winning. She felt like she should be happy about it, but she didn't care. Besides, her guardian probably didn't believe what he was saying either.

Eventually they ran out of fuel. They didn't have any food or even anything to drink. Although she wasn't hungry, Mr. Tut said she had to eat something for mom and dad. As soon as he said that, tears came to her eyes. He placed a chitin-covered hand on her back to comfort her. She looked into his face, He was a bug, just like the others. He had bug eyes and antennae, but other than that... He was a Shirren, and Shirren weren't evil, almost never. She could trust him. She sniffed and calmed down. Finally, Mr. Tut saw a gas station and they decided to stop there. They will refuel and buy some snacks. That's what Shirren said. They were on the outskirts of a town, similar to the one near her house... Mr. Tut went out to notify the staff and look into the shop. But first he started pouring fuel into the tank. However, she felt that something was wrong. It was quiet, definitely too quiet. She started to be afraid. She looked out the window and wanted to shout to him to come back, because there was something very bad here. But then there was the sound of breaking glass. A bugran out from inside, it was smaller than the ones on the farm, but it ran towards Mr. Tut . Her guardian reached for an ax he had

taken from the house and began beating the monster over and over until it fell dead, then he leaned heavily against the cab and panted for several minutes while he waited for the car to refuel before she got inside. and they set off. Lilka saw that Mr. Tut's clothes were soaked in yellow Shiren blood.

“Don't worry, I'll be fine.” he said in Shirren way, in her head. Then they drove for some time. Mr. Tut looked weaker and weaker. She even had to wake him up several times while driving. Finally he stopped in the middle of the road and said.

“I'll take a nap, I need to rest for a while. Follow the road until you reach the evacuation point. Find soldiers there, they will definitely help you.” he handed her the ax, now dirty with blood, so similar to Shiren's, and left the cabin. She took the driver's seat and started driving the car. Her parents allowed her to do this several times, but only ion the open ffields, not on the road. But now they were gone. She was alone... She wiped her tears so they wouldn't obscure her path.

Bina began to wonder why she was hanging out with that psychopath Igzar, instead of looking for a way to escape from this planet. The black-haired Pahtra looked menacing enough to make her shiver just looking at him. He gave the impression that he wanted to kill anyone who annoyed him, even though that wasn't a problem. What's worse is that he actually intended to do it. As they were leaving the nightclub, a Shirren tried to stop him and ask him what was going on, and then Igzar hit him with a rifle stock, smashing his head. She wasn't sure if Shirren had survived. Then they looked for a car, or rather Igzar told Wagar to stop the first passing car by simply standing in its way, and then Pahtra, threatening the driver with a gun, threw him outside, along with his wife and children. The orc looked at him reproachfully, but said nothing. She also felt sorry for that family, four humans, judging by their appearance, typical inhabitants of the suburbs, but if even Wagar was afraid to oppose Pahtra, what about her, who was three times smaller than Ork.

They drove along sidewalks and through parks and gardens, so they somehow managed to get out of the city despite the traffic jams. When their group left the city, she asked carefully.

“And may we know where we are actually going?”

Pahtra just looked at her. She realized that she couldn't and was about to curl up in her seat and pretend very hard that she wasn't there when Wagar, who was pressing himself in the back seat, said something.

“We're going to the Shadows of Tarak, and then we're leaving this planet.” the orc said this last regretfully. Igzar growled angrily, and Bina began to wonder. She heard about the shadows of Tarak . It was a company of mercenaries, specialists in operating behind enemy lines. They consisted largely of veterans of the Tarak Civil War, or their descendants. They were known for both their effectiveness and ruthlessness. But if the Shadows were here, that meant …

“By devils and demons.” she said. It was this Igzar, the famous war criminal prosecuted by the supreme tribunal of Absalom, or the national hero of Tarak, depending on your point of view. Most importantly, he was the sworn enemy of Admiral Antares, who also came here to defend the planet from the Swarm invasion. And since they were both here, that meant… she swore under her breath. It couldn't have been a coincidence, and since they were both here, Igzar probably had one thing in mind and she had absolutely no intention of helping him with it. On the other hand, she didn't mind staying here and letting the bugs eat her. She had to grit her teeth and cooperate with Pahtra, although she wasn't sure why they were dragging her along, but she didn't want to ask, lest Cat Noir would reconsider his decision and throw her out. On the other hand, he knew about Antares' connection with her Father. In this case, she found herself between a rock and a hard place, although in Igzar's case it was not a hammer, but a device that caused much more pain. She herself knew little about her Father's connections with Antares, only rumors repeated to her by her sisters and other employees of her Father.

While driving, she saw fiery explosions in the sky and flashes of light, and from time to time a shooting star appeared, probably the remains of a downed ship. She guessed it was a battle taking place in space. Bina had never seen anything like this and had no idea which side was winning, although she had the impression that a lot of ships must have been destroyed.

“The swarm doesn't take into account losses, so it can lose hundreds of ships and won't even feel it. Maybe if the Atrax Fleet arrived now, you would have a chance, but without it...” Igzar answered the unasked question.

“So why did you come here if there was no chance of winning?” she asked and immediately regretted it. Pahtra twisted his scarred muzzle into a particularly nasty smile and said.

“We were hired to cover the evacuation of civilians from the planet.”

She did not receive more detailed explanations from him, but she did not demand them either. She liked living too much.

After a few hours, they arrived at what was probably supposed to be a recreation center for the working class. There were several small people's republics on Kesler recent times, and they must have found one of their remnants. It turned out that the Shadows of Tarak were quartered here. Igzar's mercenaries were mostly Pahtra and or Vesca. Representatives of other races also served him, Drows, halflings, Ysokas... There was even one Skittermander here. They all looked very dangerous, including Skittermander, but they also seemed to be very disciplined and, as far as she could tell, well armed. Everyone, or at least the vast majority, gathered in what had once been a playground. The sight of such a gang of thugs between the swings was truly absurd.

“Listen to me, because I don't like repeating myself.” Igzar began to speak in a growling voice, looking menacingly at his subordinates. “As I warned you, we must escape from here on our own, because the government here was unable to defend their

planet. We will head southeast to the Evacuation point in the city of Ulm and from there we will head into the mountains. I know where we can find ships. So get off your asses. You have fifteen minutes to prepare. Anyone who doesn't make it in time will end up as food for the Bugs”

Ulm was further away than Itel expected, in fact she had been there maybe once as a child and had been taken there by car. She thought her arms would fall off from the effort. Even though she wasn't sure if she could row well, she had never done it for so long. In fact, she had never made such an effort. She was a member of the school volleyball team, but she didn't take part in training because she couldn't afford the uniform, she wanted to earn money for it. It was probably completely irrelevant now anyway. However, she needed to rest, at least for a quarter of an hour. She swam to the shore in a secluded place near an abandoned summer house and here she moored. Then she cleaned the bottom of the boat as much as she could and lay down with her backpack under her head.

She wouldn't have woken up unless the boat had moved. She drew her knife and jumped to her feet, feeling terrible pain in her overworked arms. She almost fell into the water. In front of her she saw a human woman, about fifty years old, tall and wearing an old, slightly short cloak .

“Lady! Good Lady! Let me get into the boat, there's plenty of room in it. There's enough for both!” she said in a slightly hoarse voice. Her eyes were nervous and darting.

“Don't come close to me!” she said in a voice full of fear, holding a knife in both hands. She saw the blade of her weapon tremble, so she adjusted her grip and tried to look more dangerous than she actually was.

“There is a plenty of room. Really, there's a plenty of room here.” the woman said as if she hadn't heard her at all. She stepped into

the boat with one foot. Then Itel struck. She plunged the blade of the knife into the woman's neck. She wheezed and grabbed her wound with her hands, then slipped and fell into the water. However, she did not give up and grabbed the side of the boat, trying to get inside. The boat tilted and turned upside down. They both ended up in the water, but only Itel surfaced. She looked at the boat, which was slowly moving away from the shore. All her belongings ended up at the bottom of the river. Even oars. All she had left was her knife. The blood-covered blade looked completely ordinary, but it had just taken someone's life. She considered turning the boat up and continuing downstream, but she couldn't bring herself to get into the water. So she set off on foot towards the city.

Lilka drove for a long time until her leg hurt from pressing the gas pedal. She had to dodge moving cars once or twice, but she barely noticed. She was alone, no one was with her, she had no one. She was alone in the world. She couldn't think, she just did what Mr. Tut wanted her to do. She had no idea where she was going or why. She just drove forward. Finally, she approached a larger city, around which she saw a lot of people and some vehicles flying in the sky. This was probably where she was supposed to go, although she had no idea why she got there. The whole place was surrounded by a wall and barbed wire, she saw soldiers everywhere. As she was driving inside, she almost ran over an Elf girl with green hair. The soldiers were shouting something to her, and only after a while she realized that they wanted her to stop. She braked so suddenly that she hit her head on the steering wheel. A soldier opened the door suddenly and aimed his rifle at her, but when he saw who was the driver, he pulled her out of the car. She tried to take Mr. Tut's ax with her, but it didn't stay inside. The soldiers looked at the vehicle carefully and talked to each other for a while, and then a female soldier accompanied her deeper into the camp, between the barracks, gave her a badge, and then told her to go to the supply point. She didn't understand exactly what she meant, but she went where she showed. There, another lady gave her a paper bag and two

bottles of water. The bag contained bars of something similar to chocolate, but smelling completely different. She drank the water, she didn't even know how thirsty she was, and went towards the barracks. She was alone again, although there were plenty of people around.

The column of vehicles belonging to the Shadows of Tarak was moving surprisingly fast, although Bina had no knowledge of logistics or such matters. She sat in an armored personnel carrier next to Igzar . She would have preferred to go with someone else, but Cat Noir seemed to prefer to have her on ou. Completely unnecessary, she had no intention of leaving the Shadows' company, be around them was probably in the safest place on the planet, no matter how much Igzar would want to kill her when he decided that he didn't need her. He didn't even have to shoot her a bullet, it was enough for him to abandon her by the road. She was from the B series, she was a cheater and a trickster. If she were from the K or W series, she might have had a chance, but in her case... She was at the mercy of Igzar and his gang. She decided that she had to try to be useful, or she wouldn't survive even the time she had left.

The opportunity to prove their usefulness came as soon as they reached Ulm. The soldiers, seeing a column of non-army military vehicles, ordered them to stop. Igzar went outside and lit a cigarette and started talking to an officer who looked like he had just been promoted. They talked so politely that the two men almost went at each other's throats. She had heard that Pahtra had been de facto expelled from Tarak, and she seemed to be beginning to understand why. But she couldn't allow violence to break out, because then everyone would be lost. So she approached them and began to speak in a friendly but firm voice.

"I'm sorry if there was a misunderstanding. My name is Bina and I represent the sentientarian organization Light of Hope from Atrax . We paid this bunch of mercenaries to help evacuate children from the combat zone and the planet in general."

The officer looked at their company skeptically.

“They don't look like they would like to save children.” he said, smiling crookedly, but then Pahtry, who was standing next to him, spoke up Truant.

“Of course we want to save the children! My ancestors would have disowned me if I hadn't saved them.” there was so much confidence and enthusiasm in the orc's voice that the officer began to believe him. So Bina decided to go ahead and said.

“Let's be honest, this isn't a place where there was a flood or a riot, but an attack by the fucking Swarm. We will have to fight our way through a war zone. We don't need peacemakers here, just a bunch of damn hardened veterans because no one else will keep these kids safe. Apart from that.” she added, smiling slightly. “Soldiers we hired already have supplies, you just have to provide supplies for the kids.”

The officer thought for a moment, then nodded. After all, even if he made a bad decision, no one but the gods would punish him for it.

“Okay, you can come in, but don't try any numbers or you'll remember.”

Igzar nodded sullenly, but as soon as they were inside, the Pahtra took her aside and wrapped a clawed hand around her neck and growled.

“What the fuck did you think of making my soldiers into nannies?” he growled, and she replied, smiling despite the streams of blood running down her neck.

“Think Cat Noir. If you escort the kids, absolutely no one will stop you, and they will even help you. Besides, I'm not stupid, I know that you came here because of Lord Admiral Antares . You want to fight him, fine, I don't mind at all. But the opinion of the hero who saved defenseless children will be very useful to you and will tie Antares' hands. And I think I need to tell you something else. I've

heard a bit about Shadows of Tarak. You are not an ordinary band of mercenaries who fight for money, but to avenge the fallen inhabitants of Tarak. Many of them have or had families on that planet. They may be cruel to their enemies, but they want to take care of the little spark of goodness that remains in them. If you want to keep an ear among them. – she looked at several soldiers who stood behind him and watched them. Igzar released her and began giving orders.

Lilka sat with her back against the wall of the barracks, hugging her knees with her hands. She barely noticed the arrival of some soldiers. It didn't make any difference to her, no matter how many people were around, she would always be alone. So she just sat there and stared straight ahead. Eventually the sun started to set and it started to get cooler and she felt cold. This woke her up a bit and she started walking around the camp looking for something, although she didn't really know what. Suddenly she saw a large orc who was talking to some Ysoki . Next to him he placed a large and heavy ax, much larger than the ax that Mr. Tut had. With something like this she would definitely be safe and no Swarm creature would hurt her. So she walked up to it and just took it and tried to run away. However, the orc noticed her, turned around and grabbed her by the arms, lifting her and setting her in front of him.

“Hello, my name is Wagar”

“And my name is Lika.” She said without letting go of her top

“Why do you need my ax?” he asked, smiling friendly but also a bit menacingly.

“To fight the bugs!” She said, looking defiantly into his eyes. Wagar laughed and asked.

“Where are your parents?”

Then something snapped in her.

“Dad and mom are dead... They're all dead. I'm alone...” She finally said it out loud. She roared, and the fearless warrior who was afraid of nothing knelt next to her and hugged her, for there was nothing he could do.

Considerations

Chapter Notes

This is the hundredth chapter. Please give me feedback and comment

Glimmer woke up next to Bow and stretched her wings and back. Then she kissed her almost-husband and touched her belly. She smiled to herself. She still couldn't believe that she was going to have a child. She was happy at the thought of becoming a mother, although she didn't actually plan it, it just happened... She would have wished the circumstances had been more favorable, but children were born even in the darkest period of the war, of which she was the best example. Everything will work out somehow now. She didn't even notice Bow waking up. He smiled at her, kissed her and then her stomach.

„Are you sure you don't want to tell your dad about this...„ he asked, and she thought for a moment and shook her head.

„I want to surprise him on the wedding day. But I will definitely tell him everything before we make it public. Unless this ant spills the beans.” She replied to her beloved.

„Don't call her that. Her people are called the Shirren , and her name is Ashurk” said her belovedhugging her tightly. She sighed and said with a weary voice.

„Just looking at her gives me a headache. You think all of her people are so intense?”

Bow smiled and stroked the back of her neck.

„Everyone is themselves first and foremost. We should not judge all representatives of a given people by a single representative and vice versa.” He said gently, and she thought about it. Three

days had passed since that dinner and life was slowly returning to normal, as much as possible. Catra told them what she had learned from her father. Her mother's people were called Pahtra. They didn't find out much else, but she was curious what he would be like and if they were similar to Catra or the feline people who lived in Etheria.

„We still don't know anything about my mother. I don't know if space pirates can sneak onto the planet undetected? What are space pirates like, anyway? Do they have mechanical parrots?" she asked herself and smiled to herself. "You know... If it weren't for what happened to Mom, I would be glad that she is a pirate..."

„Arr!" Bow said and kissed her neck and then asked. "What are you going to say in response to the Lord Admiral's proposal?"

She closed her eyes and moaned.

„I don't know. I don't like it, although I don't think he wants to attack us, but I don't like the presence of foreign troops on Etheria . People from outside have tried to take advantage of us too many times. We won't let them do this to us again…."

„Then maybe tell them they can only bring officers and personal guards. This will probably be a good compromise." Bow suggested.

„A bit rotten for my taste, but I guess it's the best solution." she smiled at her beloved and climbed on top of him, hugging his waist with her thighs. „ You know what, we don't have to get up yet, especially since we've already discussed matters of state importance, so I guess we have time for some... „ pleasure." she kissed her almost-husband… Only a few more days.

She had to admit that the Grand Marshal's job had been extremely exhausting lately. It was hard for her to concentrate on her daily work, even though there was so much to do. She had to strengthen the posts on the border with Dryl, and also figure out

from where transfer the soldiers who were to be stationed near the border with the Kingdom of Snow. So far they didn't have to guard anything there, they just had some bored border guards. Now they had to be on their guard, because the Frosta country had gone over to Lonnie's side. They didn't know what was happening there now. She told some Brightmoon residents who had relatives there to ask them what the situation was like in their country. Damn, they needed an spy agency, maybe they should hire Double Trouble, or one of his people to handle it. The worst thing was that she had no idea where the money would come from. In the Fright Zone, the budget was a very conventional thing, but here she had to take money into account. She must ask High Minister Shu for additional funds, although the Otter woman always became terribly suspicious whenever finances were discussed, and since the arrival of... the Lord Admiral, she had been very nervous. Finally, she decided to take some time off and went to a teahouse in the city, which was one of her favorite places to relax. Adora was trying on the dress, and although she would have loved to see it while she changed, trying on new clothes made her irritated, so she decided to leave it alone for now.

As she walked to the teahouse, she looked at Melog . Since meeting Lady Cala, her companion had been nervous, but he did not explain why. She only realized that he didn't think she belonged here. When she asked if he meant Etheria or just Brightmoon , he just shook his head and kept saying that he didn't fit in anywhere. She herself didn't like the smell of this woman, even if it sounded terribly stupid. There was something about her… she couldn't put it into words. And there was this conversation during dinner, Lady Cala actually confirmed their suspicions about Miss Daisy being Shadow Weaver... This was the main reason for her lack of concentration and trouble concentrating in the last few days. "*Focus, don't let yourself get distracted*," she thought bitterly.

When she entered the Teahouse, she was greeted warmly and taken to her favorite table, and Melog was given a pouf to sleep on. She ordered tea with milk and cinnamon, she even asked if

they had butter for tea, but they didn't, so she settled for her usual order. Melog got a bowl of milk and lemon juice, he liked this combination very much. Most of the customers tried not to stare at her, although the children glanced at her and smiled at her, and she smiled back at them with an equally friendly smile. The citizens of the capital were friendly towards her, as if they were unaware that she had once wanted to level their city. To them, she was just She-Ra's fiancée, a girl who helped save the world... She wondered how her father's subordinates would treat her? For them, everything she did on Etheria probably didn't matter, the only thing that mattered was whose daughter she was. Being privileged just because of her origins was a strange feeling... Though on the other hand, Mrs. Ka didn't have much respect for her. In fact, there was something in her gaze that reminded me of Shadow Weaver. This contempt and revulsion, as if she offended her by her's very existence. But there was something else, sparks of joyful cruelty. She hated this woman, even though she had just met her.

And again her thoughts returned to the Dark Sorceress. *Will I ever be free from her*? she thought bitterly and rubbed her temples. Then she saw Castaspella come in, so she waved at her and motioned for her to sit next to her. The Head Sorcerer looked very tired. Glimmer's Aunt laughed weakly at her and took her up on the invitation.

„You look exhausted...„ she said, and the sorceress groaned painfully.

„Everything has become terribly complicated, you can't even imagine how much. Almost everything was ready, but... our new guest made me have to rethink every aspect of the celebration! Everyone! And your... our guest is going to bring his... subordinates. Has Glimmer decided to do anything about it?" She asked almost pleadingly

Glimmer had not yet decided how she was going to respond to the Lord Admiral's request, and only then was she going to inform everyone of the arrival of the guests from beyond Empire.

„Not yet, but I haven't talked to her yet today... And can't Nightgale help you? Where she is?" she asked, because she hadn't seen the tall assistant anywhere lately.

„She received news that her sister had an accident and she needed to return home quickly to help her family." The Head Sorcerer sighed and added. "You don't really like her, do you?"

She grimaced

„"I know it's unfair, but she reminds me too much of her."

„You mean Shadow Weaver?" she asked Castaspela carefully. Glimmer's Aunt seemed to be touched by the mention of the Dark Sorcerer.

"Yes... You know, everything Aize said about that hag turned out to be true. She really made a Pact with this Nyarlathotep. But... " she leaned forward and added in a low voice. "She is alive Castaspella. This is the same Miss Daisy that was talked about at the dinner that time. She is here. I have no idea what he's planning, but I swear that if he's going to hurt any of my loved ones, then..." she dug her claws into the table top.

Asindesa di Vir felt she was falling into a bottomless pit. She came to this planet full of hope, with a heart full of love. She dreamed of a happy... perfect future with the one she loved... For a moment, for one brief moment, she tasted it, and then... Then she discovered the truth... Miss Daisy, the Shadow Weaver came from the planet that had been the destination of the entire expedition... she would have saved them all a lot problems and worries when she told the truth. But he was willing to accept that, because both the Order and the Lord Admiral had their secrets, as she had recently found out. But everything else…

Miss Daisy warned her that she was a war criminal. She accepted it because the Lord Admiral was not the hero he wanted to appear to everyone, she knew him too well to believe in his legend.

Besides, many Hell Knights had a lot on their conscience. The darkness always swirled around them, and few escaped being tainted by it. However, she served Horde, the same force that took her family away and her ruler committed evil beyond imagination. Moreover, she sold her soul to Nyarlathotepwi , another dark power. She served an enemy she swore to fight against at all costs. She was ready to give her life in the fight against his cultists, and now it turned out that she had given her heart to one of them... Such a thing was punishable by death according to the law of the Order. She didn't even have the right to cover herself with her own ignorance because everything was too obvious if you looked at it from the perspective of time. She should have guessed everything if she weren't so blinded . And there was something else. She could see the pain and hatred in the eyes of that girl, that Catra... How could she love someone like that?

There was also Lady Cala. She didn't believe that the girl was innocent and unaware of anything. She was too smart and too confident. She had to know everything. Now she saw her past in a completely different light. The mysterious deaths that haunted her family, growing up alone in Castle Grayskull, the sudden discovery of the extraordinary truth about her origins. Now it all fit together logically. But he needs to find out more.

She looked at the unusual sword she now held in her lap. As she stared at the weird inscriptions on his blade, she was sure of two things. That she still loves Miss Daisy and Hates Lady Cala Grayskull of Carurystal.

He smiled as he held the Child in his arms. Finally it fell asleep. He has been very restless lately and has had a hard time putting him to sleep. He wasn't sleeping well either... Since His brother and Shadow Weaver's visit, could that have anything to do with it?

Entrapta had been gone for almost two weeks and he was worried about her. This was probably another reason he couldn't sleep. At

first they were only supposed to visit Netossa, but then his wife sent him a message that they were going to Frosta, then that they were going to the wastelands in search of the lost city. This was a ridiculous idea! They had a lot of work here on site. First onesartifacts and Horde Prime treasures to explore. The entire island is a mystery with its secrets to search. Even the ordinary everyday matters of life in the castle required them to work together. For example, repairing the sewage system. There was no point in worrying about other things.

It was all Catra's fault. He couldn't bring himself to trust his former commander. She almost killed his wife once, and she might do it again, even if not out of malice, then through negligence. Entrapta's instinct for self-preservation was not the best developed and you always had to keep an eye on her so that her curiosity didn't get her into trouble. He considered contacting Brightmoon and asking if they had heard from his wife, though it was hard for him to bring himself to ask the princess for anything...

The arrival of Shadow Weaver also unsettled him. The fact that she survived didn't really surprise him at all. Of all the people he knew, she was the most likely to fake her own death. But what she said about this man... This Antares filled him with terror. If she really was as evil as she claimed, then hiding on Beast Island was the most sensible option. But… He couldn't just hide here. He had a debt to this planet to repay... That was the only reason he agreed to meet with Shadow Weaver, but what he would do after that remained to be seen. The only certainty was that he would keep an eye on his former second in command hands.

And then he heard over the announcement that Entrapta had returned. He felt inexpressible relief and hugged the Child tighter.

„Mom will be here soon.” he whispered, smiling at them. He really liked being a father. Making something so small and fragile feel safe. See trust and love in their eyes. It was something his Big Brother would never understand.

„Hello Hordak, hello CHILD!” Entrapta shouted, and then the Child opened its Eyes and screamed.

„Mommy!” it screamed and broke free from his hands and grabbed the furniture with its hair and ran to its mother. He tried to make them asleep for two hours.

„You won't believe what happened. We ended up in this City of Elder Things that must have used technology completely unknown to us, but there was nothing left of it, and then Lonnie tried to kill us with such an extraordinary organic weapon, I tell you, it was truly amazing, I hope I can examine it! And then we were buried, but Shogoth dug us out and Adora appeared , and then Frosta was dethroned, it's very sad... But the best thing happened at the end. Catra's father has arrived from outside the Empire!

„Catra's father?” he asked, trying to sort out the information his wife had provided him with.

„Yes. His name is Lord Admiral Antares and he has a real fleet of war. He'll be here soon and we can check them out!”

I think Shadow Weaver left out a detail he thought glumly.

Nighrgale needed to leave Brightmoon as soon as possible. It wasn't difficult to come up with a relatively plausible story to justify her departure from the capital, but it would be much more difficult for her to return again. She may even have blown that cover forever. She'll have to come up with a new identity, but this time she'll have to use a shapeshifting spell instead of an Illusion spell, because another seven-foot woman might attract attention...

It took a long time to get back to Castle Crypto. She had to first get to the place where Nightgale was supposed to live. Then she had to find a safe place where she could take Scarlet's form. Fortunately, Nyarlathotep's cultists helped her maintain her cover. They also provided her with transportation. Lonnie never bothered

to think about how her sorceress traveled so quickly across the planet. She put it all down to Scarlet's resourcefulness, which was actually very close to the truth..

As soon as she arrived at Castle Crypto, she immediately noticed that something had happened in her absence. The atmosphere was tense. Every Rebel member she saw looked scared and looked away from her. The first to approach her was Kyle . He still had that unusual sword on his belt, although he had gotten a new scabbard.

„Hi Scarlet. How good that you are here. How are you?" he asked, looking at her sympathetically. She sighed heavily and demanded.

„Just say what happened instead of going around the topic!"

Kyle looked down and said quietly.

„She's here, and she's not the only she."

She had a guess as to who he might be referring to, but Scarlet should have asked.

„Tell me who you mean. I can't read minds." she said, trying to sound angry.

„Shadow Weaver is here and she has come to us. I'm so sorry." he put his hand on her shoulder. She wondered for a moment why there was so much sympathy in his voice before she realized that Scarlet had reason to be afraid of their former lead officer, though maybe Kyle was more concerned about the real Scarlet. After all, it was obvious that she was related to the Dark Sorcerer. She herself was afraid of her mother's reaction. Will he reject her as much as her father? However, she decided to keep her blood alive in the winter and play the tough girl.

„That's even good. Take me to Lonnie. I have news of great importance for her, it cannot wait."

„Is this about the Lord Admiral, Catra's father? You know, Shadow Weaver already told us everything…” Kyle scratched his temple.” We have news for you too.

It didn't surprise her that her mother knew about the Lord Admiral and his relationship with the Grand Marshal. After all, knowing everything important had been one of her main tasks for years, and serving the Creeping Chaos also required similar skills from her. She was about to tell Kyle to take her to the General's companion anyway when she felt a tap on the back of her neck. She turned around abruptly and opened her mouth in disbelief. In front of her stood a cat-like girl, remarkably similar to Catra, she even had two”colored eyes, although her eyes were both blue and gold. She also had a strange metal arm and wore dark armor. She had a rifle on her back.

„Hey, Firehair! I guess you were my sister's friend too? I'm the second one, the scary one!”

Tirin this time participate in the council on the bridge. In fact, as a navigator, she should always have been involved, but she was often left out. To many of the crew, especially those recruited after Jadehell, she was just a crippled kid, even if she had a higher position than them. It was irritating, but she was used to it. The important thing is that the Captain respected her, the opinion of others did not matter much to her.

Breaking through the security systems of this entire Etheria wasn't difficult, at least not for the Merciless, which was designed as a Corsair ship after all. However, it must be admitted that the locals did not protect their planet very well, or perhaps they were too trusting and did not take into account the existence of ships like theirs. Merciless was too large for most landing sites in the Galaxy, and on a planet like that they certainly had nothing suitable for them.

Since the events of Wherever, Moonshadow had been visibly shaken. She didn't witness the events in that bar, but she knew that something happened there that really moved the captain. Many of the crew whispered among themselves that their captain had lost her temper again, although they used much more offensive words. Things calmed down a bit when they arrived on this planet, but things were still tense.

They stopped at a large rainforest called the Singing Jungle by the locals, quite close to the capital of this place called Eternalsong. The crew members went there to buy some fresh food, have some fun and learn something new. Captain Moonshadow decided to stay on board... Just in case. Now they discussed what they had learned and what they should do next.

„Well then." began Boatswain Kaert. „There's a big party coming up in the capital. They celebrate the victory over the Horde and... There is to be a wedding between Adora She"Ra and some Grand Marshal and between Queen Glimmer and a Techmaster Bow." The Boatswain paused, waiting for the Captain's reaction. She trembled when she heard the queen's name. She heard that Queen of Etheria was the daughter of Captain Moonshadow. When she thought about it , she felt a twinge of jealousy, although she was very ashamed of it. The captain was the closest thing she had to a mother. Her birth mother was… well, she was the reason her body was twisted. If she hadn't run away with her to the poisonous forest...

„Someone will have to go to the Capital. To Brightmoon, Captain Moonshadow said." Someone will have to find out where they keep their treasures. We will make the jump during the Victory Day celebrations. – she added. Kaert and Gydwa exchanged glances. She knew they were thinking the same thing as her. About the sword that the captain lost.

„Only the locals, if they don't have fruit jelly instead of brains, would definitely hang our memory portraits wherever possible, and to find such a Tonado, they wouldn't even need portraits,

because all they have to do is order the arrest of anyone with six hands fur ball they see.”

The first mate gave him a murderous look, but the boatswain was right. They fought with this Adora and they definitely know what they all look like... Except...

„I can go.” she said and everyone on the bridge looked at her in disbelief so she added. “No one saw me on Ikarus, probably no one even knows if I exist.”

„So the little cripple wants to be useful?” Gydwa asked her, smiling maliciously. Veska never liked her, but she won't be provoked. She simply nodded and said.

„Exactly. I am a crippled girl, petite and nice. No one will suspect me of being a pirate. Besides, I have nothing to do as a navigator anyway.”

The others began to consider her words, but Captain Monshadow looked at her with concern in her eyes.

„Are you sure you can handle it?” she said, and Tirin felt herself blushing behind her mask.

„I swear I do. Captain. I know that I must be strong, that I must be brave, but I can really be like that!”

The Winged Pirate looked at her for a moment, then nodded and said...

„Agreement. I hope I don't regret this”

Death in His eyes

Chapter Notes

Here's another entry in my Fan Fic. Kane is Created by Karl Wagner. Please leave your comments and opinions.

Bina woke up and started looking around. She was in a large leather tent, lying on a thick layer of blankets. She wasn't sure what planet she was on or what had happened to her recently. She only remembered that it was something terrible. She was probably in some underground place where something attacked them, she was probably fighting powerful being in tomb and then... something happened earlier. She was supposed to warn someone about something, something extremely important. Suddenly her eyes widened as she remembered who she was thinking about. Her kids... Miss Daisy is a Shadow Weaver! She jumped to her feet and immediately doubled over, feeling a shooting pain in her arm. Oh yeah, she got hurt fighting a damn Archon . She cursed several times, getting up slowly this time so as not to be overwhelmed by a wave of Pain again, and then moved to leave the tent. She needed to get to Brightmoon as quickly as possible . He has to save his kids...

„Take it easy, tough guy. They say that scarlet owls will chew up the weak and spit them out, but on you that would probably break your teeth.” Huntara said with respect in her voice. She offered her arm and helped her outside.

Tung there Lashor, and members of his gang who occupied the camp . As soon as he saw her, Tromlin waved at her friendly, still with the whip in his paw. Zgniotek was parked far away from the camp. His back was turned towards them, which indicated that he was offended. He could be extremely irritable and moody.

„How did you manage to get him to give you a ride?” she asked with undisguised surprise in her voice.

„It was not easy. At first he didn't want to let us in. Tung Lashor wanted to challenge him to a duel and they both loved the idea, so I literally had to wave you in front of the mask to convince him. He asked if it was the small cars, I don't know what he meant.” explained the Princess of the Wastes.

„ It's his quirk, out of respect for your mental health, it's better not to delve into it.„ She explained and tried to move forward, but the pain shot through her again and she offered her arm to Huntara again. “I need to get to Brightmoon as soon as possible. This bitch is alive and has my kids. You understand? I brought her here... I didn't know she was her. I wouldn't have agreed to bring her here if I'd known who she is

„What are you talking about?” Huntara asked, looking at her with complete lack of understanding. Bina wiped her forehead and said.

„We brought your Shadow Weaver, that nasty bitch you were talking about! Wrongdak’s brother right hand woman. You know, Hordak’s Right Hand ….

„She's dead, it must be someone like her. The dead stay dead, there is nothing more certain in the world. – Huntara said with a mixture of confidence and concern in her voice. She looked at her with concern. I guess she thought Bina was crazy. But then Tung Lashor approached them.

„Maybe not here, but necromancy is widely practiced in the galaxy. I remember one time we had a campaign promoting a new line of bone whitener. It didn't sell well.” said the lizard with sadness in his voice. Huntara looked at him like he was crazy.

„Well, once I saw in some store a product advertised as "Providing natural bone whiteness"„ she said thoughtfully. “But what am I talking about? We have to go to Brightmoon because that bitch

kidnapped my kids. Fuck, that's why she was so fascinated by Eti...”

„Who kidnaped Cat-girl?” Tromlin looked at them suspiciously .

„Your Shadow Weaver. I brought her here, although in my defense I had absolutely no idea who she was.” explained A Tung Lashor looked at her in surprise.

„The Shadow Weaver was the undead! That would actually explain a lot.” he scratched his with his clawed fingers. She shrugged.

„She didn't seem to be undead, but I don't know anything about this sort of thing. Maybe Lady Cala… Holy shit!” she cursed when she remembered the young aristocrat.

„What Lady Cala?” Huntara asked with resignation. She was clearly overwhelmed by the recent news.

„Miss Daisy's ward... this is Shadow Weaver. Lady Cala is Shadow Weaver's ward, a very wealthy aristocrat from Carurystal, though I'm not sure what their relationship really is. She claims to be a descendant of that Mara, but I don't know how much truth there is in it, especially now it seems suspicious. We transported her and the other members of her expedition here, and then Cala took some of them to go to one place... How long was I unconscious?” she asked Huntara .

„Two days... „ said the older warrior, and Bina uttered a string of curses.

„I don't know if they're still alive. If this girl is what Dilayla thought she was…” Bina bit her lip. Of that group, she appreciated only Dilayla. Arkan-tar, Rechiza, Doctor Quin didn't concern her. They weren't very nice to her kids, who were the most important people to her. She had to save them at all costs... Even at the cost of several other people's lives.

On the other hand, she had no idea where to look for Shadow Weaver. She had no ship or other support, apart from Huntara and

Lashor , and she wasn't sure she could rely on the latter. Perhaps the queen would be willing to listen to her, especially when the desert warrior was with her, but... Damn, she couldn't leave them to die... Perhaps they were okay and continued their excavations safely... But could she have them on her conscience... She remembered. about a that family that Igzar left Kesler for dead while taking their car. Motherhood had softened her, and once she would have had no scruples about letting them die. She sighed and said.

„Okay, I'll go to Brightmoon, you find Lady Cala and the rest... I'll give you the coordinates, I think I even have their communicator frequency. Try to capture Lady Cala alive, but I warn you it won't be easy. She is an incredibly formidable fighter and if you have no choice, don't hesitate to take her out. Huntara , could you write me a letter of introduction or something like that, because I need to contact the queen as soon as possible and warn her." Bina said and started packing.

Kane looked around. He was in the middle of hills covered with dense vegetation, mostly short, thorny trees and bushes. The area was desolate, although the planet was generally not densely populated. There were probably a dozen or so million creatures living here, maybe twenty at most. Even his Carurystal, which was called a galactic village, was a metropolis compared to Etheria , although on the other hand this place could not be denied a certain charm. It reminded him of the old days, before the young races took off into the stars. Although how long ago was that? How many millennia have passed since then? He couldn't count, and it didn't really matter anyway. What happened will not come back, longing for what has passed is vain. At least that's what he always told himself, perhaps deceiving himself. Nostalgia had always haunted him, and sometimes the weight of the past centuries overwhelmed him so much that he was unable to do anything else but drift in the ocean of memories. One hasn't experienced this for a long time. Since arriving on Carurystal. Perhaps it was due to the Break, which had deprived him of much

of his memories. Maybe it was the nature of his planet, where so little had changed, that was responsible for this. He wasn't sure and preferred not to go into it, he was enjoying this short period of respite. A peace he didn't deserve.

After the first meeting with Shadow Weaver, he had a feeling that this woman was bringing great changes, that she was not who she seemed. He was sure of this when he found her in the library, looking for information about Krannor Rill. He considered killing her before she destroyed his wonderful oasis of peace. He could have sent assassins or some terrible demonic creature after her, but something told him that this was how it should be, that nothing lasted forever. That he cannot hide for eternity from the inexorable rush of history, turning away from the universe, because the universe will not forget about him. That's why he joined this expedition organized by Prince Zed and Doctor Sidonius, fully aware that he would probably never be able to return home.

However, there were also other reasons why he went on this expedition, although he realized some of them only after arriving on this planet. At first he thought it was the first bout of nostalgia in centuries. He felt like deja vu, only much stronger. Memories flooding him from all sides, as if they were trying to materialize in his mind, but at the same time fading into nothingness at the last moment. He guessed what it meant. His mind reacted differently to the Gap. It didn't completely deprive him of his memories of his old life, it just made them hazy, hidden behind translucent glass. He could sometimes decipher them with some effort as long as he was near an object or place associated with it. And this place brought back shadows of many memories, not very pleasant ones... No, it wasn't, it wasn't precise sentnce. It would be better to say very dark. Something terrible happened here a long time ago and he was involved. Unfortunately, he couldn't remember anything specific. He remained as unaware as the nice inhabitants of this planet.

Their ship Memory landed near Eternalsong, the capital of a country ruled by Princess Sweetbee, a strange winged Lashunti.

The capital had suffered greatly at the hands of Horde Prime and was now being rebuild. For this reason, many inhabitants of even distant kingdoms, such as Salinea or the Kingdom of Snow, came here and helped with the reconstruction. The native inhabitants of the region, mainly the local variety of Lashunta and Strix, showed them some reserve, but considering what they had experienced during the war, they showed them much more cordiality than they could have expected. Prince Zed and Dhampir Daughter of Doctor Sidonius paid a visit to the Princess, Doctor Sidonius had gone to Brightmoon for a purpose known only to him, and he had come here to seek... He wasn't sure what. Probably his own past, although he wasn't sure if he would like what he found...

On the other hand, he wasn't sure if he would find anything here. So many centuries had passed... At first glance, Etheria seemed like a place where time had stood still, but even here, constant and inevitable changes were taking place. The landscape was changing, and even if his memory hadn't been obscured by the fog, he still wouldn't have been able to recognize this place. But he could have searched them in a more traditional way. In his time, he had explored many of the ruins left by the Elder Races, guided only by vague references in forbidden tomes. He was really good at it, almost as good as he was at killing. Unfortunately, the results of these searches were usually far from expectations.

This place was not always as desolate as it is now. When he climbed one of the higher hills, he discovered that the terrain showed that it had been leveled in ancient times to make a road for heavy vehicles, perhaps tanks? It would not be easy to notice something like this for someone who was not as familiar as he was with the remains of ancient technological civilizations. However, there were traces of a much more recent presence of Intelligent beings. Paths in the forest, remnants of camps that have been broken up many times over the decades. He even found traces of dragging a large block of rock. Most of these remains were at least five years old, if not older. This was not surprising, because recently the locals had gained access to much more efficient means of transport...

However, he eventually found something much fresher. Clues of a group of Humanoids , including one wearing power armor, which suggested that they may not be from this planet. They didn't try to hide, they were very confident for guests on a foreign and unknown planet. It was very interesting. So he decided to follow in their footsteps and he did a very good job. He came to the top of a hill where he saw a statue. It represented Chaugnar Faugn, one of the less influential Old Ones, largely because his followers shunned civilization, his much less monstrous descendants were much more influential. The sight of the statue, while definitely disturbing and thought-provoking, was actually irrelevant considering the reason he had come here. It was far too new and made with tools too primitive to be the work of one of the ancient civilizations, and it did not stir any of his memories. Much more important was the place he seemed to be guarding. It was a tunnel leading deep underground, where something extremely important was hidden, something he almost remembered...

Centuries spent in the safety of Carurystal made him lose some habits, but his wild instinct of a murderer, a predator who without blinking an eye shed the blood of anyone who stood in his way. Therefore, although he forgot about caution and did not sneak to this place as he would have done in the old days, he still dodged a second before the attack. A beam of electricity hit the spot where he had just been standing. The beam was fired from a weapon held by Strix woman, and her Lashuntian companion stood behind with a machete. Stryxa looked at him in bewilderment, clearly not expecting her target to dodge, clearly he had no experience in fighting, so he jumped at her, stabbing her with a dagger into her throat, then jumped at her companion and knocked her to the ground with a shoulder blow, which caused the woman to release her weapon. He grabbed her hand by the wrist and pressed it to the ground.

„Tell me who you are and what you are doing here!” he growled menacingly, staring at her with his blue, cold eyes that reflected death. The sight of those blue eyes of his often made others more terrified than a blade held to their throat.

„Lady, she told us to. Let's all keep an eye on this place. And she ordered her to take care of the prisoners, even though the latter had taken them. We… „She burst into tears, clearly unable to cope with the situation, so he spoke in a calmer voice.

„Who are you, who are they and these prisoners?”

„We are the servants of the Mistress Of All Life.” she mentioned the name of one of the gentlest aspects of Shub-Niggurath . “Lady Cala participated in our rituals and then ordered us to come here and take care of the people trapped here. But we're not like that, we just want to honor life in all its aspects, and those... They were terrible. They worship this horror, whose statue was built here. But even they weren't as scary as Lady Cala. She seemed nice, at least at first, but then she turned out to be a monster ... Those people, they want to sacrifice them. I'm just a teacher, I didn't sign up for such things. I never wanted to hurt anyone. I don't really want to die anyway. Please don't hurt me.”

He thought about her request for a moment and decided he would spare her. He was neither merciful nor cruel, and did not kill or harm others unless he felt the need to do so. He became curious about the issue of prisoners. They certainly had extremely important information. However, they were probably guarded by fanatical cultists and perhaps worse things. Did he really want to risk his life for them? He thought for a moment. He was genuinely curious about what they had to say. He has already risked his life for lesser reasons...

„Which direction did they go?” he asked in a gentle voice. The woman showed him which direction to go, tracking down the cultists dragging prisoners behind them probably won't be difficult. He decided to let the woman go, rather she would stop worshiping the Ancient Ones once he understood what it entailed. But then he heard a scream.

„No thorny weed can stop the great Tung Lashor!”

Well, someone who shouts throughout the forest that his name is Tung Lashor is certainly not a cultist of the darkness beyond the stars. He could also use some help, he was a good warrior, but it's always better to have support... So he ordered the woman to stand up and let her go ahead.

She stared at that idiot Tung Lashor in disbelief. She never thought they would work together one day. What's more, she was just discovering that he wasn't an idiot, at least not like she had previously thought him to be. Somehow he got here from outside Etheria. He's someone as extraordinary as Adora and Hordak . Until now, everyone believed that only two people had arrived on Etheria during the time it was hidden in Despondos, but it turned out that there was a third one right under her nose, and one with connections to some great power outside the empire. She didn't understand much of Bina's story , except that the Aspis Consortium seemed dangerous. She didn't say whether she might have hostile intentions towards Etheria and it was difficult to learn anything specific from Tung Lashor.. He began to tell his gang members about the greatness of the Consortium, even though he said terrible generalities or things that they did not understand at all. Now, for example, he was praising meat mondays. She was sure of one thing. From an ordinary idiot he became a dangerous idiot.

With Bina they separated two days ago. Tung Lashor gave her two members of his gang to escort him to the Valley. He chose those who seemed to be quite composed, especially Kublodka, who seemed to be quite sensible. The burgundy-haired traveler lent them this strange carrier, even though traveling in it was one of the most terrifying experiences. The vehicle drove itself and, deprived of its owner, paid no attention to the health of its organic passengers. He took them as far as he could, which was definitely further than she wanted. It was definitely too much for her old bones. They followed the directions of Tung 's Datapad, Bina uploaded the appropriate data to him. They had to make their way through the jungle, and neither she nor the Aspis chief knew

the area well, but several of the reptile’s subordinates were from here, so they made their journey much easier. They were almost to their destination when they heard the snap of branches and suddenly two people emerged from between the trees. One of them was the Vespid woman. She seemed both terrified and distraught, like a criminal caught in the act being led into custody by the entire village. Her hands were even tied. However, it was her companion who attracted much more attention. He was a tall and powerful man. He had reddish-red hair and his face looked wild, even brutal. His eyes were the worst. Cold, light blue. They seemed to emanate an inner glow. She felt as if Death itself was lurking in them. He was dressed in a surprisingly elegant outfit, resembling a suit or uniform, but he seemed to wear it like armor. He was armed with a sword and a pistol, although he also had a rifle on his back. He looked at her and she shuddered involuntarily.

„I'm Kane. I can help you.” he said, his voice completely incompatible with his powerful and barbaric figure.

„ What's the point... „ Tung growled Lashor approached Kane but he looked at him and the lizard doubted his abilities.

„I've been following you for some time and eavesdropping. You could only go to this place for three reasons.” Kane continued, smiling gently. „Either you are cultists who want to perform dark rituals here, or you are looking for ancient ruins of the First civilization, or you want to free several people imprisoned by these cultists in order to assemble them into cultists. You are definitely not cultists, and in the remaining two cases I can help you.”

„How? We have to save my friend's companions. If you can lead us to them, we would love to have your help.” She said, completely unsure if she should trust him.

„Not only will I take you to them, but I will even help free them. I kill things and I'm pretty good at it.” his eyes lit up and she realized that death really was lurking there.

She woke up with a terrible headache. She tried to reach out to check the damage, but something was holding her hand. When she opened her eyes, a wave of nausea and pain washed over her. Even though it was dark around her, she saw flashes of light. She hoped she didn't suffer brain damage. She looked at her hand, it was handcuffed to the floor, her legs were tied with chains. They did not look very strong, those who put them on did not know the possibilities of modern military prostheses. However, before she could free herself, she had to find out what happened to her and where she actually was. The last thing she remembered was Lady Cala, with a surprised face, throwing a backpack filled with explosives at them. The plan was good, but they didn't expect that this bastardess would throw it so quickly.

She saw Rehiza staring glumly ahead. Her hands were tied tightly behind her back. Next to her lay Arkan-tar, looking thoughtful, and Dr. Quin, who looked obviously pissed. Ysoka looked at her and said furiously.

„Oh, she's already awake! Great! Now break those chains and break some heads until the brains fall out from between your fingers! These idiots broke most of my equipment. I rented some of it and now I will have to buy it back with my own money! Ignorant people like them don't deserve to live.”

Well, it must be admitted that Ysoka's breve spirit gave her some encouragement. She tried to get up, but then she felt dizzy. She felt nauseous and vomited. Rechiza turned to her and smiled wryly.

„You got hit in the head really hard. You lay covered in boulders for several hours, so we weren't sure if you survived. In fact, if it weren't for those bastards trying to take your armor, you'd still be lying there. Maybe that would be better for you?”

She didn't like Laszunti's words or her resigned tone, but the Warper had always been a fatalist. Dilayla wasn't going to give up.

„Maybe you'd better tell me what happened!” she growled, and then Arkan tar spoke up in a very tired voice.

„ You took most of the shock wave, so it was only bruised. Unfortunately, the tunnel was buried and we were trapped for several hours, maybe even a whole day, until we were dug out. Unfortunately, the people who did this were cultists, I didn't expect them on this planet, but considering who Lady Cala and Miss Daisy are, and what the statue we found represented, it shouldn't surprise me at all. The aristocrat, of course, survived the explosion that no mortal could. They dug us out and detained us immediately. We tried to resist, or rather, Rechiza tried, but they teargassed us and electrocuted Rechiza... Really, someone should start requisitioning the Horde's old equipment, because it ends up in the hands of those who shouldn't. They somehow took off your armor, I admit I helped them, because they were going to cut it with a blowtorch and then they brought us here.”

She sighed and asked.

„Where is it HERE and can you guess what they are going to do with us?” the mercenary asked in an irritated voice.

„ Some complex of caves and gorges. They made their base here. I think they're organizing or something.” said Verthani, and Lashuntka added.

„They are mostly followers of various Great Old Ones, emigrating all over the planet to worship various beings in their holy places. They are led by Nyarlathotep's cultists, but they do not dominate here. And what are they going to do with us... It's probably quite clear. They want to sacrifice us to Chaugnar Faugn, or rather to one of his brothers, which is somewhat ironic considering the history of this place.”

Dilayla sighed heavily. Everyone had their time. It was important to choose how to leave.

„Over my dead body.” the mercenary growled.

They came for them in the evening. They didn't seem to care that Dilayla was conscious, luckily for them. They led them out of the cave in which they were held and led them to a low hollow in the center of which was a statue of Chaugnar Faugn. Arkan-tar could tell at first glance that there was something unnatural about him. The stone it was made of seemed almost organic. His amazing glasses had not been taken away from him, and he could see the shadows of his past swirling around him. He didn't really like what they were doing, but that was what he expected to see.

The cultists were among the many species that inhabited Etheria, and most did not appear to be true fanatics. They seemed more scared than Verthani's companions. However, the group of followers was large enough to enforce obedience. They were lined up in a row in front of the statue and a woman dressed in black robes.

„The Cultist of Nyarlathotep, along with the cults of Great Cthulhu and Hastur, are the most powerful, but it is rare for their cultists to lead rituals for other ancient ones. Apparently they have a staff shortage." Rechiza murmured quietly, and the priestess began to speak.

„Embrace your shadows. Look deep within yourself and release what you hide in your own hearts. Listen to the whispers coming from the darkness. To ascend, every being must free itself from the shackles that society imposes on us. Embrace your shadows, for they are your true Self. Follow your instincts. Surrender to your innermost desires, your darkest emotions, for only a free being can rise to create your own destiny. " the woman spoke and rubbed her hand, then placed it on the statue and then began to chant in Aklo, the language of the ancient races. Unfortunately for him, Arkan-tar knew this language and his bones shuddered when he heard it. So then it was time to act. Dilayla broke the shackles and shattered the skull of the nearest cultist with one powerful blow, while she grabbed the Electric Baton from the other and shocked him with it. At the same time, a laser fired from Ysoka's

cybernetic eye, hitting the priestess in the base of her skull, killing her instantly. With her hands bound, Rechiza could not cast spells, but she was able to distort reality, causing the cultists to start suffocating in poisonous fumes, and Verthani took a knife and began to cut the Warper's bonds.

The four of them moved back closer to the statue, their backs to it. They probably won't survive this fight, but it's better to die in battle than to be slaughtered. He smiled bitterly, because this was not the fate he expected when he joined this expedition. But then he heard battle cries from everywhere and a swarm of warriors ran on ropes into the valley. Most of them were lizardmen, kobolds, and other creatures with the symbol of the Aspis Consortium on their chests. They were led by Tromlin with a strange whip and an orcish woman. However, the greatest slaughter was caused by a huge man with blood-colored hair. Arkan-tar was sure that death itself lurked in his bright blue eyes.

After less than a minute, the fight was won with no losses to their relief side. Almost all the true cultists died, the rest surrendered.

„I'm Huntara, Bina sent me here to save you... Is Lady Cala alive?!” the orc woman asked.

„Unfortunately, she is difficult to kill.” Dilayla said, smiling evilly.

„We'll see... She hasn't met me yet. As you saw, I'm really good at killing.” said the man with eyes like the heart of winter.

A bit of tenderness

Chapter Notes

> Well, here's the next chapter. I must admit that I really liked Nightgale. Please feel free to post your comments and opinions here.

She was present on main plaza, when Lonnie swore her not-so-temporary wards as friends of the Rebellion, a military formation specially invented for them. She had to admit that Comrade General showed exceptional composure, because Bina's wards were not used to official ceremonies. Alatar was constantly looking into the Datapad, Lilka was fidgeting and looking around. Eti stared at Lonnie with her head tilted to the side, like a cat curious about a small defenseless animal, of course, only when she wasn't translating to Rosie what the Comrade General was saying. The glasses that allowed the deaf girl to understand what others were saying to her still hadn't been repaired. Now she stood with her head down, scared and lost. The perpetrator of the whole situation, Itel, stood to the side sullenly, not very good at hiding her guilt and anger. These were the children she had been entrusted with, and now she had to take care of them, even though Crawling Chaos himself knew he was not fit for it. If it weren't for the Lord Admiral, cursed by devils and demons, she would have liked to have sent them back to Brightmoon, where they would have been better taken care of, although the wild beasts would probably have taken care of them better than she ... What she wouldn't give to be able to drink something stronger.

„Okay, that's all from me for now. Any questions?” Lonnie turned to her new rebels and was very surprised when all five of them raised their hands .

„Can I see your computer servers? And in general, you have a terribly cumbersome interface on your computers. Has anyone here ever heard of computer mice and ergonomic keyboards? – Alatar asked

„I really need pumpkin spice for real orc pumpkin pie... and chocolate! And some popcorn ! And corn too! Because the Bone Festival is approaching! The coolest festival! Orcish one!” Lilka said, jumping up after saying each sentence.

„When will we finally start doing something instead of talking pointless, meaningless shit?!” Itel asked in a sharp voice.

„I don't have any questions, but Rosie has two. When will you fix her glasses and gloves so she can talk to us again, and when will I get the tank?”

Lonnie stared at them silently, only the twitching of her eyelid giving away her annoyance. She took a deep breath and answered the kids in the order they asked their questions.

„We have the computers we have, you have to deal with it. The spice is in the third warehouse on the northern ledge, ask the quartermaster about the rest. You don't decide when and what we will do, you just listen to orders. We're working on fixing them, and you'll get the tank over my dead body.”

Everyone, more or less satisfied, dispersed, except for Eti, who looked at the Companion General for a moment before she spoke.

„So it was a figure of speech, not a proposal? Ok, but think about it, I'm sure i’m a great tank driver.„ the cat girl said, but Lonnie gave her a dark look, so she waved her hand and said. “Okay, I'm going with Sparklepaw to look for Blonde boy, I'm sure he misses us.” Eti and the white-haired girl went along.

Lonnie was about to head back to her quarters, but then she spoke

„You did it well, Lonnie.” she said, coming closer, but Comrade General gave her a suspicious look.

„ What do you want? I know you're not saying this out of the goodness of your heart... „ she growled sharply.

„It's just a statement of fact.” she tried to keep her voice impassive, even though she knew that her former protégé was right, at least partially.

„All these years you spoke kind words Only to Adora, and even then only when she was polite and obedient, so leave the flattery... „ Lonnie spoke angrily and then smiled, causing the scar on her face to twist nastily. “Were you this nice towards Glimmer too? I heard you taught her sorcery...”

She nodded and said in a thoughtful voice.

„Glimmer was an extremely bright student, perhaps the brightest I ever had, even surpassing her father...”

Lonnie let out a short laugh.

„If one of us showed such talent... Tell me, would you get rid of him yourself or organize an accident?” she asked, walking up to her and looking her straight in the eye.

„I don't know, honestly. Hordak hated magic, even mine, but I doubt he would let me condemn someone just for being talented, if not out of compassion then to annoy me and provide me competitor. Fortunately, we will never have to find out.” she said, and then Grizoll approached them . His species in the Galaxy was known as Bugbears and had a disreputable reputation. She didn't know much about his kin on Etheria, the former Force Captain was the only one of his species she'd ever met and their relationship wasn't very good, though she couldn't actually recall having a good relationship with anyone since leaving Mystacor. Not as a Shadow Weaver.

Grizoll spoke to Lonnie in a low voice for a moment, and then the Comrade General looked at her and smiled again and said.

„But I guess you'll be able to see what you would do if one of us started using sorcery... Do you remember Scarlet?”

She barely remembered Scarlet. The red-haired cadet stood out mainly because she was almost inconspicuous. Now she understood why. The only sorceress of the Rebellion was waiting for them near the castle entrance gate, next to the car repair shop. Eti was talking to her, and Rosie was standing next to cat-girl, looking at everyone with a slightly frightened look. Since fight with Itel, the deaf girl had been withdrawn and lethargic, not least because of her inability to communicate with others, not including Eti. What happened there was unbelievable and she had no idea what it could mean. The girl had already shown amazing abilities, especially for a intern, but the Galaxy was full of wonders. She saw many completely unknown kinds of power, Solarians drawing power from photons and gravity created energy weapons and armor, Vangards using the power of Entropy protected and destroyed, and Evolutionists constantly mutated their bodies. The fact that the girl was able to lift the truck was amazing, but what happened to her magic... Rosie not only resisted her spell, but actually began to drain her power, like a leech devouring her, perhaps even would have consumed her if it weren't for withdrew its power. Now she had to wonder who... or what the deaf girl was. Rosie herself had no idea who she was and stayed close only to Eti...

The mystery of the cat girl... both cat girls was explained... At least to a large extent, because she had the feeling that there was something else hidden in the whole story, the last piece of the puzzle... But she didn't even know which way to look to find it... But at least Eti was safe, but Catra... What plans could her father have for her? And also towards Adora and the rest? What could he be planning? She knew she had to find out and warn both girls about him in some way. That's why she needed Lonnie's help...

It's just that there was a certain Risk involved in being here. Almost all members of the People's Rebellion knew her and knew what she was capable of. Many were former cadets and saw with their own eyes how he treated Catra and hers other students. How will Eti react when she finds out how she hurt her sister? The scout herself suffered a lot and it is doubtful whether she would forgive her. And it was only a matter of time until he found out the truth. She liked to pick on the cadets, especially Kyl-, who knew her well... It was good that the blond-haired boy didn't hide any secrets. He had some ridiculous sword on his belt, from what she had heard, it was a treasure he had picked up on his last expedition, kids like him often got attached to worthless things, and he was in a relationship with Lonnie and Rogelio, but apart from that he was just Kyle .

„Good afternoon, Scarlet." she said, trying to sound as neutral as possible. The Sorceress turned to her abruptly and said.

„ Good afternoon Shadow Weaver... I'm so glad to see you safe and sound." although her voice was calm, she could feel the tension in her, which was understandable, although she had the impression that there was something incongruent with the whole situation, but she couldn't say what.

„I'm glad to see you too. And congratulations on discovering a new talent, one of the many advantages of my absence on Etheria." she said, trying to smile in a friendly way, but she could feel that Lonnie and Kyle were watching her with great tension, as if they expected that tentacles of darkness would soon rush towards the young sorceress to choke the life out of her. This would have been unlikely even in the old days, she knew much more subtle ways to eliminate those who stood in her way, but the fears were fully justified. There was a very awkward silence, which was broken only by Eti.

„Apart from Grimmy, we also have another spellcaster . Her name is Ireanis, and unlike your former boss, she can be really dangerous." when she said this, she also translated her words into sign language. Scarlet looked at the cat-like girl again, and her

face showed surprise combined with disbelief, a very common reaction to Eti's words...

„So there are more of you? – Never mind... I bring very important information, although from what she has heard, some of it is known to you, but probably not all of it. There are still a few important things we need to discuss.” said the younger sorceress, turning to them. She nodded, but said.

„Agreed, but I'll solve one problem first... „ she said and saw that Lonnie and Kyle looked at her worriedly, apparently thinking of another way of solving problems. Well, what he is about to do will also cause others pain, although of a different kind than they expected.

Itel stood with her back against the wall and stared at her blade, which she summoned and unsummoned mechanically. She tried not to think about what she had done. Or what Eti said. But it was impossible. Eti's words kept ringing in her ears. " but nothing more ". They resonated in her soul, tugging at it and tearing it to shreds. She hadn't realized before how much she loved the cat girl. That love, never spoken aloud, but she could always hold on to. It was a support, an anchor that helped her control her anger. The same anger that caused her to lose her. She was furious with that deaf girl. For lying to them. She knew from the beginning who they all worked for. She may have been unaware, but if they had known the Lord Admiral was coming here then... It wouldn't have changed anything. She persuaded everyone into this expedition to find a cure for Captain Blazebringer. It is more important than anything in the world... More important than even than... than love for Eti? She rubbed her temples. Wasn't it possible to have the one you love and get revenge at the same time? “You can't have another person's love, you can only receive it.” She remembered a quote from some idiotic book of Alatar. She wanted to cry and scream like a little child, but she couldn't. She hadn't been able to since Kesler's destruction .

„I think we should talk.„ she heard the voice of Miss Daisy, or rather Shadow Weaver. She immediately pulled herself together. He won't show weakness in front of that bitch.

”I have nothing to tell you!” she shouted to a woman who emerged from the shadows between the buildings. The dark sorceress looked at her with a serious face. She felt as if those strange yellow eyes were looking deep into her soul. She shuddered. She hasn't worn a holographic mask since they arrived here. Everyone in the rebellion feared her, and it was becoming increasingly difficult to look at her as a useless old woman

„Unfortunately, I think we need to discuss recent events, although I'm probably not the best person to do so.” she sighed and continued. ”But there's probably no one else here with enough experience.”

Itel let out a broken laugh.

„Don't try to play the caring nanny here! I have eyes and ears. I see how they look at you and hear what they say about you.”

Shadow Weaver smiled grimly.

„ Indeed, my past has caught up with me here and I will have to face it, but it does not concern you.” the Dark Mystic was saying, but Itel interrupted her.

„We are here among your former wards, so I guess it concerns us.” she approached the gloomy elf so that she could look her straight in the eye. “And Eti? What do you want from her! I know how badly you treated her sister! Do you think that if you are nice to her, you will redeem yourself? "Bullshit," she smiled contemptuously, but then stepped back as the shadows lengthened and darkness swirled around her. Several former cadets looked their way. They seemed scared. Maybe she overdid it this time... But she won't humble herself... She won't apologize.

„I didn't treat her badly, I just tried to turn her life into a nightmare. You don't know how many nights she cried... How

many times she screamed in pain when I punished her for the slightest insubordination, or simply when I was in a worse mood. And the worst thing was that she wanted my love all this time, almost until the very end. I raised Adora with the belief that she deserves love only if she gives everything she has, including her life. I was no better to Lonnie, Kyle and the rest, and that's just small part of the evil I did. There is no redemption for me, I know it well... I can only avoid making the mistakes of the past... and prevent others from following this path." Shadow Weaver sighed deeply and withdrew the darkness she had summoned. "I know what love is... And I lost it, irrevocably and forever... But you don't have to lose it. There are different types of love. Maybe you won't get the one you want, but you can replace it with something else... Some say that friendship is a much deeper and nobler feeling... Perhaps you will also manage to meet someone who will love you back. Life sometimes disappoints us, but it also surprises us positively." said the Dark Sorceress and left her alone with her pain and sadness. Itel sighed heavily and left as well. She had to find Eti and Rosie and do the last thing left to her.

Rosie stared at Kyle explaining to Eti what life was like in the Rebellion, or at least that's what she thought, because despite Eti's efforts, the cat-girl was unable to translate everything what the blond-haired boy was saying. She felt as if she had gone back to the very beginning, to the moment when she was found by the research ship. Back then she didn't have glasses or gloves for a while and had no idea what others were saying to her... No, it was much worse now. She was already used to this equipment and now she felt completely helpless. She had to wait for it to be fixed, but at the same time she was very afraid of it. What others will say about her. She saw fear and distrust in the eyes of the others, except for Eti and, surprisingly, Kyle, though in the latter case she didn't understand why. This fear was fully justified. She finally did something terrible, she almost killed her friend, if it weren't for Eti, she would have succeeded. And the worst thing

was that she didn't remember anything. It had happened to her twice before. Once during training with Lady Cala, and the second time when Captain Moonshadow attacked Adora, but in this cease she didn't hurt anyone. It definitely had to do with her extraordinary fighting skills. She had always enjoyed them so far. She had found them useful many times during this expedition, using them to defend herself and her friends, but now she suspected that they had the same source as the power that filled her when she fell into a trance. She could never afford it again, now she was even afraid to train with Eti that she would hurt her.

Suddenly she felt a hand on her shoulder and she turned around abruptly, instinctively taking a fighting stance, but she immediately relaxed and lowered her head when she saw that Itel was standing in front of her. She felt ashamed. At first she hid the truth from them, maybe she didn't know that it was so terrible and that the Lord Admiral was the father of Eti and that Catra, that he was someone evil. And then she tried to kill her ... if she hadn't been stopped... Then Eti said something that hurt the elven warrior greatly. I guess she knew what she meant. That they, Eti and Itel will no longer be together. It was probably her fault too... Now the Solarian was trying to talk to her, she seemed sad instead of angry as she should have been. For a moment she didn't know what to do, and then she threw her arms around the elf's neck and burst into tears. She tried to apologize, but it was difficult to speak sign language when hugging someone. Itel also started crying and hugged back. After a while, Eti approached them. A tear rolled down the cat”like girl's face.

„Whose side is this Lady Cala on?” she asked the Dark Sorceress. Shadow Weaver and Scarlet were in her quarters, a rather modest room furnished only with a table with maps and a few chairs. She was apprehensive about their meeting, she knew her former lead officer well enough to guess that she wouldn't take kindly to the presence of the competitor, but it was surprisingly calm, perhaps even too calm. She didn't fully trust Scarlet, but she didn't trust Shadow Weaver at all.

„Lady Cala and I share a common mission and I believe... No, I am sure that I can count on her in this respect, but I cannot guarantee that she will support your cause, even I cannot force her to do anything.”

She smiled, crookedly, at her former superior.

„It's surprising, you never had a problem with forcing others to your will... „ She felt more and more confident in her presence. Is it she who has lost her old fear or is it the Dark Sorceress who has changed

„Apart from Adora and Catra... Doesn't that mean that they were my best students?” Shadow Weaver said, looking at her with a hint of amusement. Scarlet rolled over.

„Maybe instead of making fun of each other, we can start discussing serious matters, Shadow Weaver, what exactly did you come here for?”

„To find out the location of Eternia ... What I do with this knowledge is my business, but all, or almost all, Artifacts of the First Ones will be yours. Even if you simply want to sell them all, you will get such a price on Abbalon that you will be able to finance your rebellion for years, or even better, buy the entire planet for Your. explained the Dark Sorceress.

„I'm not going to leave Etheri.” she snapped back sharply, such a possibility had never even crossed her mind.

„So what are you going to do?” Hordak's former righthand man asked with a hint of curiosity in his voice. She hesitated before answering.

„For now, we intend to attack during the Victory Day celebrations. We'll hack into Brightmoon's database , make some noise, declare a Great People's Rebellion, and kidnap Entrapta .

Shadow Weaver nodded at the first points, but her eyes widened at the last one.

„Why do you want to kidnap Entrapta ?!” the Dark Sorcerer exclaimed in surprise. She thought about her answer for a moment.

„We found an ancient First One warship. We need Entrapta to repair it.”

Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes.

„ Is this your new allies' idea? Listen Lonnie, creatures like Mi”Go are not the least bit trustworthy. – Hordak's former Right Hand was saying , but he didn't let her finish.

„I've been listening to you all my life! Enough of this! You are no more trustworthy than Mi-go! Now go out and inform your new charges about what I have decided because I expect them to help me in this entire mission. March back.” she ordered, aware that she was trying to convince herself.

Nightgale didn't like Lonnie's Plan much, so she would have to think about how to help her perfect it, though for now she had other things on her mind. She had to do something she had been preparing for and dreaming about all her life. This was something she was so afraid of. But she had to do it.

„Shadow Weaver, I need to show you something... Follow me „ she said, trying to sound as natural as possible.”

The Dark Sorceress looked at her in surprise and nodded. Aaravos hovered next to her, watching her curiously but saying nothing. They went deeper into the castle, wandering through countless corridors, she had the impression that she passed the same chambers several times, although she couldn't be sure because she didn't know the purpose of most of them. Sometimes she was sure that the layout of the castle changed every time she walked through it.

„This place is like Entrapta's mind .” Shadow Weaver muttered. She nodded. They finally reached their destination, although she wasn't heading to a specific part of the castle, but simply wanted to get as far away from prying eyes and ears as possible. She started taking off her clothes.

„What are you doing?” asked the Dark Sorceress.

„Not what she thought.” she replied and unraveled the spell. Pain beyond all imagination shook her body, and then she took a deep breath, feeling the strength of her real body. She turned to her mother.

„Who are you?” Shadow Weaver asked with surprise, although he didn't hear the disgust in her voice, it was a good start.

„Scarlet called me Nightgale, a twist on the word nightingale. She never had any magical talents, but she had a good heart. She took care of an unfortunate creature wandering alone underground in the Fright Zone, which was created and then rejected by Hordak, who wanted to create a new Right Hand, using his and his former long-time Second in Command's genes.” she said, staring at her mother's disfigured face, which showed shock and disbelief. Absolutely understandable reactions. She waited a long time to see what would happen next. Will she face rejection or acceptance? Her heart was beating, her muscular body was covered with sweat. But then the Dark Sorceress, the one who had destroyed so many lives, smiled sadly and extended her clawed hand to her.

„ Good evening Nightgale, nice to meet you, my daughter.”

And then Nightgale ran up to her and hugged the Dark Sorcerer, finally she wasn't alone,

Bonus Chapter - Saving Throw!

Chapter Notes

> A very short chapter, not entirely canonical. This is my version of Roll with it. I invite you to comment and express your opinion.

They were in the War Room belonging to the People's Rebellion. Comrade General Lonnie sat at the head of the semi-circular table, and Eti, Rosie, Itel, Alatar, Lilka, and Kyle sat across from her. There were lots of polyhedral dice, sheets of paper, manuals, maps, and miniatures on the table. The latter came from Alatar's resources or were made by Kyle . Lonnie looked at them seriously.

"I guess we'll start... " she said slowly.

Lilka's plan.

An extremely tall and powerfully muscled girl with arms as thick as tree branches was riding a gigantic and very cute blue Fox. In her hand she held an ax capable of cutting the tang in half, and on her head was a horned helmet with horns. Opposite her were countless ranks of Orks, huge and heavily armed orcs.

-We are gathered here to fight together for honor, goodness and freedom! Many of us will die today, but it doesn't matter, because for a true orc, dying in battle is the highest honor... as long as we brushed our teeth and cleaned our ears first. For the Horde! – She led her orcs towards Brightmoon.

Lonnie: *We are no longer part of the Horde!*

Lilka: *But it's the good Horde, the orcish one.*

Alatar: *You won't find the Ork Horde in the area either, and besides, you have to convince, charisma is your dump stat.*

Lonnie: *And who are these orcs anyway...*

Alatar: *Has you seen Huntara? Some of the orcs are just like her, only wilder and more warlike... The rest are a bit like clones...*

Lonnie: *Okay, next plan.*

Eti's plan.

Eti's plan.

She walked through the dark halls of Brightmoon Castle. Its black corridors were decorated with skulls and demonic symbols. Terrified servants hid in corners. The warrior with a long tail and a powerful metal fist effortlessly dodged half-naked, twin-bladed, and very sexy female warriors accompanied by monstrous feline beasts. The warrior avoided them without the slightest effort, but in several cases she had to stop because the warriors or equally scantily clad and sexy sorceresses wanted to hurt someone from the servants, always a beautiful woman. The warrior then eliminated the guards silently, unless there were too many of them, in which case she defeated them with her incredible dexterity and masterful hand-to-hand combat skills. The rescued girl always placed a kiss on her lips. She finally reached the Witch Queen's Throne Room. Glimmer sat on a huge skull throne. She was even more scantily clad and sexy than her guards. In her hand she had a wand with a bird skull on the end. When she saw the warrior, she burst into mad laughter.

“You think you can beat me, you sily girl! I, Witch Queen Glimmer, dark ruler of Etheria, will crush you and devour your soul! Bird of Doom, tear this wench apart.” then a monster appeared from between the shadows, looking like a combination of a cat and a raven. It was about to attack the warrior, but she quickly jumped on the Queen to deal her a fatal blow.

Lonnie: *Neither Brightmoon Castle nor Glimmer Castle look like that!*

Eti: *You probably didn't know her as well as I did.*

Lonnie: *I've been leading the Rebellion against her for several years...*

Eti: *But you know how she tastes like*...

Lonnie (after a moment of dismay): *I don't want to get into the nature of your relationship.*

Alatar: *Eti, will you show me your dice? Because I don't know how you managed to have almost the highest rolls on all attributes and critical successes in all tests?*

Eti: *Because you have to know how to roll the dice, dude.*

Kyle : *Why did Rosie look sad every time Eti kissed those girls?*

Lonnie: *Next plan*

Itel Plan

Itel rushed into the palace. The elf held a great, huge blade in her hands and was dressed in luminous armor. Following her, the entire Tarak Shadow Legion entered Birightmoon. They had to hurry, because the queen had betrayed her country and was going to marry the Lord Admiral as a dowry, giving him all the weapons of doom she had hidden in her treasury. Most of the inhabitants of the kingdom were imprisoned in the dungeons. The Lord Admiral's soldiers stood in front of them. Itel sliced through them with her blade one at a time, gracefully dodging the gunfire. She finally stood in front of the Lord Admiral.

“You're about to get your well-deserved punishment!” the Elf exclaimed, but then the Lord Admiral pointed to two figures tied in

the shadows. They were Eti and Catra with explosives tied to them.

Alatar: *And now it's time for a certain Technomancer Dragonkin to step into action.*

Eti (Looking over Alatar's shoulder at his notes): *Why did you let Itel use home rules but not me! That's why I had to cheat.*

Lonnie: *It was completely absurd.*

Alatars Plan

Alatar's plan

The moons were rising over Brightmoon as a huge silver shape floated over the mountains. It was A gigantic dragon with a wingspan so large that it seemed to cover the horizon. She rode him an elven warrior in emerald armor. The dragon roared and breathed flame.

Lonnie: *Can Alatar really turn into a dragon like that?*

Eti: *No. He is only a Dragonkin, i.e. a small dragon, although for his species he is quite large.*

Alatar: *Hey!*

Lonnie: *Eti, you will translate for Rosie...*

Rosie's plan.

Hundreds of guests gathered in the large, wonderful and somewhat fairy-tale-like main hall of Brightmoon Castle as Catra and Adora's wedding was about to take place. However, when Castaspella, who presided over the ceremony, asked if there was anyone present who did not agree to this wedding, Lonnie, who

for unknown reasons had white hair, came out of the crowd and walked up to Catra and knelt down in front of Catra.

Lonnie: *What? Do you think that i have a crush on Catrra? I recently tried to kill her! And why do I have white hair?*

Eti: *From what I heard about Catra and Adora, this is probably what your mating habits are like.*

Lonnie: *You guys are scaring me, let's move on to the next plan.*

Kyle's plan

Kyle just went to pee. They were in the woods and were about to launch Operation Freedom when Kyle hit a rock. Then a tall skeleton with glowing eye sockets appeared before him, holding a staff topped with a shining gem.

"I am Tar- Baphon , the Whispering Tyrant. Killer of Gods and Immortal Lord of the Undead! I'm about to devour your soul!"

Kyle: *But why me!*

Alatar*: I have no idea how it happened. According to the random encounter table, there was a one in a million chance of this happening!*

Lonnie: *So it must have happened to Kyle. Now my turn.*

Lonnie's plan.

They were just launching ship hidden under the ice. Everything was going well... Too well, because as soon as they left the planet's atmosphere, the AI took control of the ship and it turned towards Etheria . A planet-destroying beam shot out from its hull .

Lonnie: *What?*

Alatar: *You failed your perception test, that's why you didn't notice there was something wrong with the ship. Everyone knows that ancient artifacts are dangerous...*

In love and at war...

Chapter Notes

I invite you to comment and express your opinion

In love and at war…

Adora felt confused. Getting married seemed like a simple affair. You have to say a few words in front of the moons and kiss. And then there was a big party until the morning…. The hardest thing happened before… before their first kiss, when the war was going on and they were trying to kill each other. The weddings of Scorpia and Perfuma, Mermista and Sea Hawk, and even Hordak and Entrapta went without any problems, the only major event was always looking for Glimmer in the morning, because when she was tipsy, she sometimes teleported to strange places. For example, to Madam Razz's cottage... Now even that didn't threaten them, because the queen was pregnant and couldn't drink. But this wedding became something complicated... In many ways.

First of all, it turned out that Catra had a father... That probably meant she had a father-in-law, right? Mermista had a Sea Hawk mother, called Mountain Falcon, and her two husbands, who, however, were not the captain's father... Scorpia had parents in”laws... and three brothers”in”law, huge bearded men, very protective of their "Little Sister"... Now she will have a sister”in”law too. If they can get her out of Shadow Weaver's clutches...

That was probably the worst. Many thought she had forgiven the dark Sorceress after she sacrificed herself for them, but that wasn't true, not entirely... She simply couldn't hate someone who was no longer there and would never meet. Why fuel your anger when you could find happiness in love? But if she survived, if she deceived everyone... She was the master of lies... Catra had seen through her lies long ago, but this woman had manipulated her all

her life, and then she did it to Glimmer in her moment of weakness... Had she done the same to that girl? Catra's sister claimed that they couldn't trust their father... But wasn't that what Shadow Weaver wanted from them? Once again sow the seeds of discord and distrust between friends and relatives…

The Lord Admiral seemed to her to be a decent person. He exuded calm and self”confidence. He was always polite and composed. She liked him a little, he didn't treat her like a heroine who saved the universe. It was…refreshing. He actually seemed more interested in Catra. It was good, her beloved finally deserved attention. But... She wasn't jealous that Catra had found her family... She just expected that she would be able to find her family. Light Hope must have kidnapped her from somewhere. There must have been other First Ones out there somewhere, perhaps even mourning their lost child... Maybe even searching for him across the vast expanse of space. She guess they should go on a quest to learn about her past and where she came from, even if it might mean digging into her people's past again... But only after the wedding and after... after saving Queen Angela... If that was possible. She didn't even want to consider possibility of failure. This time she won't let her down.

She slammed the boom shield as hard as she could until it bent, then dodged and landed another punch at the bot behind her. It fell over and started smoking. She smiled, happy with her success. Her mood improved slightly. She ordered the Training Room to end the session and go get a drink of water, but then she saw Asindesa standing in the doorway in full gear.

„Oh, how long have you been here?” she asked, wondering how this woman could move so quietly in this armor.

„A few minutes, but you were so absorbed in the fight that you didn't notice anything... I have the impression that you tend to focus on what you're doing.” said the Hell Knight in a gentle voice. She smiled bitterly

„Focus, don't let yourself get distracted... „ She looked at Asindesa. That's what she always said... Shadow Weaver... It still rings in my head. Even after all these years, I can't get rid of these words. “ The knight nodded thoughtfully and grabbed one of the training sticks.

„Would you like to face me?” she asked, smiling friendly.

„Sure why not.” she said, although in fact she wasn't sure whether she should fight with this woman. There was something strange about her. These Knights somehow reminded her of the Galactic Horde... Or the Dark Sorceress. They had an ominous aura around them, as if there was darkness in their hearts. It was disturbing, but then again, this Asindesa seemed quite nice. A bit too stiff in Catra's opinion, but she liked the woman's discipline and seriousness. She didn't say it out loud, but she kind of wanted to be like her... Minus the darkness and ominousness.

As soon as she assumed a fighting position, the knight attacked her. Her strikes were powerful, pushing her back every time she blocked her attack. All blows were performed systematically, they were not instantaneous, so they could gain power. The knight tried to put her on the defensive, accepting her counterattacks on her forearms. The training system could sense whether the blow was strong enough to penetrate the armor, but she failed to do so. However, the knight did not break through her defense either. Finally they pulled away from each other. Both of them were in great shape, but both of them were breathing heavily after the fight, although she noticed that the older warrior controlled her breathing faster.

„You fight well. I take it they taught you all this in the Horde?” She asked Asindesa, and she nodded and answered.

„Mainly. I trained a bit with the Brightmoon guardians, and with Light Hope, but mainly in the Horde. They pushed us hard since we were children.” she said, smiling sadly at her memories. She used to not realize what a terrible childhood they had, she was convinced that everyone lived like that. The Hell Knight nodded.

„So you were orphans taken in by the Horde... It was the same with me and the order.” she said thoughtfully. “It hasn't been an easy life, but I've enjoyed it so far... But I had a choice, at least to some extent. Although I am the adoptive daughter of Lictor, the leader of the Order of Eclipse, I could have left, although it would not have been easy, but I do not regret it. The path that the Hell Knights follow is not easy, but someone has to do what we do... It is necessary. Someone has to carry this burden.”

She nodded, because she understood all too well what Asindesa was talking about . She-Ra's power was also a burden, though it was hard for someone who didn't bear it to understand. If it weren't for Catra…

„But I guess there's someone in your life who helps you carry them, right?” she asked on impulse, but Asindesa's face showed pain

„There were many women in my life, but they were only one-off affairs... I fell in love once and I was sure it was mutual ... But it was all a lie. That woman couldn't love. Next round!” the Hellknight shouted and charged at her almost without warning. This time she attacked more violently, almost furiously. She wondered if it was the reminder of her heartbreak that had provoked Asindesa to fight so hard. When they broke apart this time, they were both soaked in sweat.

„It was uh ... „ she said, unable to find the right word.

„A little too much uh , I'm sorry I gave in to anger.” said Asindesa. It took a moment for them to regain their breath, but again the knight did it first.

„I have to learn this someday.” she said, wiping her forehead. The effort allowed her to clear some of her anxiety and worries. Asindesa also looked a bit more relaxed. She smiled slightly and spoke in her strong but surprisingly polite and gentle voice for such a formidable woman.

„These are relaxation techniques that we learn in our Order, although we have not developed them. It was created by the Iori monks, the goddess of self-perfection and enlightenment, thousands of years ago.”

She grimaced when these gods were mentioned again. This one made her anxious.

„Ah, these gods... There's so much talk about them... Sometimes even some people behave as if I were one of them... It's a bit... embarrassing... „ she said very euphemistically. The Hellknight nodded and asked.

„Could you show me what you look like when... you become the other one, tall women?”

She looked at it uncertainly, but closed her eyes and straightened her hand, and then shouted.

„For the Honor of the Graysckull!” she shouted and flashed with multi-colored light. The knight of hell covered her eyes with her hands and looked at her in shock

„By Asmodeus' black cloak... „ Asindesa shouted You really look like Iomadae.

“Yeah, everyone except Etherians says something like that. I guess it's the height and the lights, but I'm still the same girl... I swear!” she said and laughed nervously, but Asindesa shook her head.

„No, you don't understand. You look like Iomadae.”

„I heard that name.” she said, and the Hell Knight shook her head.

„You really don't know anything here. You look just like her, the Inheritor. Iomadae is a defender of the oppressed, an honorable warrior fighting evil, whose light illuminates even the greatest

darkness!” she shouted. Hearing these words, she moaned and said.

„Please don't say things like that... I'm still the same person I was before.” she was aware that there was desperation in her voice. Asindesa's words reminded her too much of what she had heard in the stream of light. She shuddered and involuntarily transformed back into her normal form. Asindesa wanted to say something, but then Lady Cala Grayskull entered the Training Hall and said.

„Can I train with the successor of my great ancestor?”

Asindesa di Vir gave Lady Cala a warning look. She didn't like this woman's sudden appearance here. She undoubtedly had evil intentions towards... Probably everyone, and hand-to-hand combat training was the perfect opportunity to hurt someone in a way that could be considered an accident... The noblewoman responded with an equally cold smile.

„Of course, we can face each other... „ Adora said, smiling at the aristocrat. She was not wearing training clothes, although the dress she wore was suitable for fencing. Despite this, Adora offered the girl a mask, but she refused, claiming that nothing would happen to her, and the heroine of the Galaxy did not insist.

„I will stay here to observe and referee.„ he said, smiling friendly, although she touched her sword warningly, looking at the Aristocrat, who only smiled in response. There was something unnatural about this lenient self”control.

She had been contemplating her situation for the past few days. She wouldn't be the first knight of Hell to be deceived by the servants of the Dark Between the Stars, nor even the first to fall in love with one of them... But she was the Lady of Blades, holding one of the highest positions in the Order. More was expected of her than of other Knights. She had already made up

her mind that as soon as this expedition was over, she would relinquish her title and submit to the judgment of the order, although there could only be one outcome, but she had long ago come to terms with death. But for a moment, she hoped there was a future for her. She was so stupid... In fact, she hoped that when she died, her broken heart wouldn't hurt so much anymore... But first she had to know the whole truth.

During her last days, she was occupied with three things. Training, gather information on Shadow Weaver as discreetly as possible and observe Lady Cala. Well, training had always been a part of her everyday life, and finding out something about the past of the woman she loved was easy because the people of Etheria were very trusting. What she discovered confirmed everything she had learned from Miss Daisy, although the truth was much worse than she could tell from her words. She had thousands of lives on her conscience and served the Horde for over two decades, she was the most hated person on the planet. However, she found no evidence that she was a cultist. Actually, the locals knew very little about not only cults, but religions and gods in general, which was quite surprising.

Lady Cala was a much bigger problem. She wasn't a spy or an investigator, and the fact that she was one of the few foreigners present in the castle didn't make things easier. She had only seen the Aristocrat a few times, and apart from that state dinner with the Queen, she hadn't had the chance to talk to her further, but now was the chance to at least get a better look at her. She could only hope that he wouldn't do anything to Adora. This woman is something of a demigoddess or even more. She had never met anyone like her in her life. No wonder Miss Daisy... Shadow Weaver saw something unusual in her. She couldn't sacrifice it for the sake of her search for truth

Lady Cala and Adora faced each other. The noblewoman had chosen a fighting stick slightly shorter than the one wielded by the Etherian girl and held it like a dueling weapon, in one hand with the other held above her head. Adora looked at her in surprise.

"You fight like a Sea Hawk," she said, and the aristocrat nodded and said

„This is a popular technique among those who specialize in the noble art of dueling. Encore!” she exclaimed and charged at the surprised warrior. However, she quickly entered the fight and recaptured Lady Cala's "Blade" and launched a counterattack. What she had previously told Adora about her skills was not tinged with politeness, honor dictated absolute honesty in such matters. The Etherian girl truly was one of the best, if not the best swordswoman she had ever fought. But the aristocrat was her equal. Lady Cala's fighting style was more formalized, perfect for anyone who specialized in dueling, while Adora was taught a battle style. At first, this gave the Aristocrat the advantage, but the Etheri warrior quickly adapted and slowly began to push her to the other side of the training hall. Then Lady Cala changed her tactics and tried to trip the warrior from Etheria, apparently the nobility of the art of dueling ended when you started losing. However, Adora managed to block it, dirty tricks were also taught in the Horde. For a moment, a grimace of rage appeared on the aristocrat's beautiful face, but then it disappeared, and now she began to attack with greater aggression, trying to land a blow at all costs. It was at this moment that she noticed something strange. Lady Cala closely resembled She-Ra , not Adora but the being whose form she assumed . It was disturbing, but then something much stranger happened. The Etherian Warrior launched a powerful attack and Lady Cala's legs bent at angles impossible for humans. She then growled furiously and pushed Adora with all her strength in the chest. The heroine of the galaxy groaned loudly, but her legs did not buckle under her.

„I guess I won... „ The noble girl exclaimed happily, but she was interrupted.

„ Look to the side!” she said, smiling and approached the training girls, and Lady Cala inhaled sharply. Adora's stick was touching the Aristocrat's side

„ If it were a real weapon, your stomach would be ripped open, or maybe even cut in half. We are dealing with mutual murder. This is common in training or sports fights when no real weapons are used. But Adora landed her strike a little earlier, and if it had been a real fight, the pain would have prevented you from throwing the thrust with full force, and at most you might have hurt the Hero of the Galaxy.” she explained to them and Adora smiled at Lady Cala.

„You'll do better next time. With the exception of Catra, I've never trained with anyone as good as you.” she said and extended her hand to Lady Cali, who, wearing her constant mask of a polite smile, smiled back.

„Yes, I would do better next time.„ said the Aristocrat. “They trained you quite well in this Horde. Isn't it the work of Hordak's right-hand man , what was her name... Shadow Weaver?” she asked with a slightly wider smile, and the joy on Adora's face dimmed slightly.

„ Yes, although she was not good at fencing, but she was able to... motivate. She put so much pressure on us that all of us, cadets and instructors alike, did not dare to disappoint her, and only perfection could satisfy her.” Adora looked into space, thinking about her sad childhood. Lady Cala put her hand on her shoulder, and then she said.

„ I feel sorry for you, but at the same time part of me envies you. Since I became... orphaned , I was missing someone who would be willing to instill discipline and rules in me. Someone who would encourage me to do my best… Perfection. Initially, I hoped that someone like that would be Miss Daisy, which was partly true, after all, she is a very smart woman and was knowledgeable in training young people. As she always told me, focus, don't let yourself get distracted. She instilled some good habits in me. but she herself was not a person worth imitating. She had a problem with alcohol abuse, but I already told you about that. She was also quick-tempered and easily angered, and her bouts of melancholy... Well, she was a very emotionally unstable person. In fact, she was quite pathetic, almost contemptible.” she shook her

head with pity. Throughout the entire speech, Adora stared at the beautiful aristocrat, growing paler and paler as she clenched her fist hidden behind her back. However, she did not show her emotions. Lady Cala was also unfazed. She told her whole story in the same unwavering, gentle voice, as if she did not realize the meaning of her words. She smiled at Lady Cala's and held out her hand.

„How about another training fight? Just you and me?„ she asked, and the Aristocrat turned her head, resting it on her shoulder.

„How about Fight to First Blood? " asked the noblewoman from Carurystal. She narrowed her eyes and nodded.

„Agree to your responsibility." she said, wondering why the Aristocrat agreed to this fight, since she certainly knew how much "love" she had for her. This could end tragically... For Lady Cala's or her. Didn't she want to take the opportunity to kill her by faking an accident during training. In a fight with such a great warrior, the chances were equal... However, she accepted the risk of death in this fight, if only she hoped to kill this woman... She had a certain advantage...

„Of course, you'll take off your armor, I assume?" Lady Cala asked, smiling good-naturedly…

She had just lost her advantage, but now she had no choice. She pressed a button and the armor fell off her. She wore only short pants and a blouse underneath. Adora offered her a protective suit, but they both refused.

„Do you know that this is quite brutal? And I say this as one I grew up in the Horde, where we were regularly electrocuted every time someone hit us... „ Adora said, looking at them uncertainly.

„We are not afraid to shed a little blood." she said, drawing her blade. The Hero of the Galaxy gasped loudly at the sight of him.

"This is the work of the First Ones..." she said with shock in her voice. She smiled at her and screamed.

„If you say so! Encore „ and charged at Lady Cala, whose expression was pure terror. The noblewoman took out her sword and covered herself with it, but then both women were enveloped in the darkness summoned by the Knight. Asindesa learned to fight in the dark, an ability she used to fight against cultists and other lesser servants of the Dark who could not see in the darkness. However, when her blade hit the place where Lady Cala had been standing a moment ago. Instinctively, she jumped aside, narrowly avoiding the noblewoman's thrust. She punched her in the face and felt her nasal septum crush under her fingers. She jumped out of the sphere of darkness, because apparently Lady Cala's gaze penetrated it She looked at the noblewoman and was surprised to see that the noblewoman's face was fully healed, only a few drops of blood were visible on her upper lip. She smiled at the Knight with a predatory smile and attacked her fiercely, but then Asindesa swung at the noblewoman, as beautiful as death herself. Lady Cala obviously wasn't risking her life at all when she agreed to this fight, but the Lady of Blades' sword made her fearful for some reason. Whatever the Carurystal noblewoman was, she was definitely not human, and she was determined to trick everyone into it, even if she had to cut the noblewoman in half!

With each subsequent blow, the aristocrat retreated more and more and was happy to see the desperation on her beautiful face. She smiled at her and Lady Cala swore viciously and suddenly her attacks became faster and more brutal, so it was Asindesa who had to retreat. She had the impression that something had happened to her opponent's body. Her arms and legs were a little longer and more muscular, and for a moment it seemed as if her pupil had spread all over her eye. However, the Hellknight did not give up. She fought demons and swarm monsters. She pinned the sword to the floor and reached for her wrist to pinch it so the noblewoman would release the weapon, but then Lady Cala grabbed her hand and effortlessly bent her arm. She looked at her with a cruel smile, but then a bright, almost blinding light flooded them and an authoritative voice rang out.

„Stop it now!” Adora shouted in She-Ra form and both women immediately obeyed her order.

„Are you guys crazy?” she asked in a sharp voice, clutching her magnificent sword in her hand. – Do you want to kill each other?

Asindesa saw out of the corner of her eye that Lady Cala was trembling as she stood in She-Ra's luminous aura. It was very interesting... The knight knelt before the demigoddess and said.

„Sorry, battle fever has set in... This is common among those who have spent their entire lives fighting.” she said, and Adora nodded understandingly, although a bit uncertainly.

„For me, training took precedence. I sincerely apologize to everyone if I caused you any fear, but it all only looked so dangerous, there was no real threat to us.” Lady Cala added, smiling friendly, but at the same time she was constantly looking at the blade. Adora looked unconvinced, but there was little she could do since both culprits were taking the blame. The lady of the blades felt like bursting out laughing because the whole situation looked like something at school, but in fact there was absolutely nothing funny about the whole incident.

„You can leave, but you are not allowed to train in the castle. I'll talk to Glimmer and Catra about it. I should take away your weapons, but I would probably cause a diplomatic conflict... How I hate diplomacy!„ the Etherian warrior returned to her natural form and wiped her forehead. Lady Cala bowed obligingly and left without even looking at Asindesa. The Hellknight also headed for the exit, but Adora stopped her.

„Where did you get this sword?” She asked, looking at her carefully. Asindesa hesitated. She wasn't sure if she should tell the truth to this woman. But she didn't want to lie to her.

„I received it from a dying warrior... „ seeing the silent question in the eyes of the heroine of the Galaxy, she added. „He wasn't

someone like you... He wasn't a biological being, although he referred to himself as he/him. I don't know much else."

Adora nodded seriously.

„You don't know how dangerous the artifacts of the First Ones are... Better get rid of him."

The Lady of Blades looked at her sword.

„It's an extremely sharp weapon, but that's all. It has no extraordinary powers, it is only as dangerous as the arm that wields it." She swung the blade several times. "And mine is really strong."

Adora continued to look at her seriously until she finally spoke.

„This sword is called "End of Eternity„ Blade of Vengeance. For whatever purpose it was created, it is not good.

Asindesa di Vir, Lady of the Blades of the Order of Eclipse, knew in her heart that Adora was right, but on the other hand... If it inspired fear in Lady Cala... then it was worth the risk.

„Sometimes you have to use all necessary means to defeat a greater evil. We Hell Knights know something about this... „ and she left the training room without waiting for the Hero of the Galaxy's reaction.

Bina decided that she really liked Brjghtmoon. It was a peaceful place, full of contented citizens, but it was not one of those good cities where anyone who stood out was treated with great suspicion. The local inhabitants knew what the war was, even though they won theirs. Perhaps if her children lived here, the wounds in their souls would heal, but it wasn't that easy... After all, she still had to find them and rescue them from the clutches of a woman as evil as Hell itself.

She learned that the Deadly Sword of Burning Fury had landed here a few days ago, but had flown away at night in an unknown direction. She could only curse her misfortune, but she had no clue. She stayed at an inn owned by the brother of "friend" of Huntara . She slept in the warehouse. In the morning, as she was wondering where she should go, she heard the Queen's official radio announcement.

„Dear citizens of Brightmoon and all of Etheria. It's me, Glimmer Moonbright . I have extremely important news for you, whether you consider me your Queen or not. A few days ago, a very important guest arrived. His name is Lord Admiral Felix Antares, and he commands the Research and Exploration Fleet sent here by the greatest powers of the Galaxy to investigate Prime's Empire . He also announced that he was the father of Grand Marshal Catra, which surprised us all. The Lord Admiral announced that he had no hostile intentions towards us and asked to be allowed to attend his daughter's wedding with several of his officers, to which, after much consideration, I agreed.”

Bina showed no outward emotion. But inside she felt cold. She had never been very religious, but she always hoped that the gods looked after mortals and made sure they were happy. At this point, however, she came to the conclusion that the gods simply had a sick sense of humor, since they allowed three people in the entire Infinite Galaxy to be on one planet who should never meet... *Four, let's not forget about this cursed by the devils and demons Hag.*

Confessions of poor and vile souls

Chapter Notes

> This is a new chapter! It took me a long time to write it. The Castroval Paradox is the paradox of a liar saying that he is always lying. Your comments and opinions will give me great pleasure.

They talked as Lonnie surveyed the rebels. She knew they should have avoided it in public, but she couldn't help herself. Not only because she brought her news about her charge. She had to admit that Lady Cala had done better than she expected. She got into the Palace without harming anyone, which was quite an achievement considering her... temperament. She managed to establish friendly relationships with Glimmer, Catra and Adora, as well as the Lord Admiral. None of the above boded any good, although it made the implementation of their plan much easier. Of course, Calamity wouldn't be herself if she didn't express her petty malice, but in this case she played it well. Cutting yourself off from all connections with her, at least emotional ones was wise. She wasn't sure whether her former wards would believe that the Aristocrat knew nothing about her mentor's nature, but it certainly sounded very credible. In the end, she worked for a reputation as a liar and manipulator... She didn't know what Lady Cala did with the other crew members, probably nothing good, but she didn't really care. Except for Dilayla, who became friends with Rosie, but the rest could die. But she hoped that Bina was okay. She took good care of those kids, better than she thought, and they would have very bad time if something happened to her.

But that wasn't why she had been unnerved for the last few days. "I have a daughter. By All That Is Holy and Cursed, I have a daughter.” She thought, still unable to believe it. She has made many amazing discoveries in recent weeks. First she met Eti, then she learned the fate that befell Queen Angela. Soon after, she found out who their employer actually was, came across Heart Gift, and finally discovered the secret of Catra's origins... And now

this... At first, she stared at this unfortunate creature, at this girl, and wondered what she was supposed to do? She wasn't ready for such a situation. She reached out to her because she had no idea what else she could do. Then she said the words out of reason rather than emotion. She didn't want to alienate another potential ally. It didn't cost her anything. But then she hugged her and felt something. She couldn't quite put her finger on it, but it was something new that she couldn't name. She had to work it out somehow.

„But How... Where did you come from and when... How old are you?" she asked, unable to judge Nghtgale's age.

„Chronologically five, and mentally and biologically something like twenty-five, based on human standards." her daughter replied in a low, breaking voice

„So you were created when I was in Brightmoon." She said and started to guess some things.

„Yes... Then, when Catra was imprisoned and Hordak needed a new successor for his right hand, so he came up with the idea of creating a new version of you, obedient like a clone... „ Nightgale said, smiling sadly.

„So Hordak is your... father?" she asked, and the pain on her face was both confirmation and denial. She sighed and stroked her head with a clawed hand. Most were afraid or disgusted by her touch, but not her... Which was understandable... After all, she obviously carried the same curse as her... 'Damn fool,' she thought, gritting her sharp teeth. Hordak never really believed she was cursed... He thought it was some form of genetic defect. It irritated her, but she gave up trying to explain the difference because she realized it made him trust her more. Her magic fascinated him, too, but it repulsed him in equal measure. Did he think that this new version of her would teach him the secret of Magic and thus prove that it was always just a science that was not understood. She had no idea what was going on in this brainwashed man head and she didn't really care now. She was

sure of only one thing. Hordak must die. As slowly and painfully as possible. Not because he created this unfortunate creature without truly understanding what he was actually bringing into being. But because he rejected her. However, this is a matter for the future. First, she must secure the future of her other daughters who have suffered so much because of her.

„Mother... I need to rest now... My body gets very tired when I am in Scarlet's form. Now it didn't take long, but then I won't have the opportunity... „ said the girl, and she nodded her head affirmatively. It took her over two hours to get back to the outer part of the castle... She got lost twice in that damned fortress! Lets the Daemons curse Entrapta and her damn ancestors. She went to the room she shared with Ireanis, where the sorceress from the Lost Golarion was playing some simple game given to her by Alatar.

„Are you tired of talking to your former students?” the silver-haired Woman asked without taking her eyes off the Datapad screen.

„Different than I expected. Although I should actually expect that they won't be happy about my return... „ she said and became lost in thought. She had to deal with everything that came her way on her own. Even though the difficulties were piling up before her, she couldn't ask anyone for help. She was lonely, as always. Even when she could have had a family, she rejected this possibility, choosing power and pride... until she became a slave to darkness beyond all imagination... Yes, she had always been alone until now...

„I have to ask you for help.” she turned to the Elf, who put down the Datapad and looked at her seriously. “ I've never asked anyone to do this before, with one exception. always thought it was a sign of weakness. Only contemptible, pathetic creatures ask others for help, and in that case you have the right... No, the obligation to demand the highest possible price. But now I am a pathetic and contemptible creature. And I am asking you, Ireanis, war sorceress, for help, because the lives of many innocent beings

are at stake. You can demand everything from me in return, although I warn you in advance that I can't give you much.”

„I'm a pathetic drunk myself... Stupid funny Ireanis, who is unreliable because she can't even cast a single spell correctly... Shadow Weaver, the very fact that you're asking someone like me for help is an honor for me... And it tells you how much you need help.” the silver-haired Elf walked up to her and put her hand on her shoulder. She looked at the strange sorceress, wondering if this was the first friend she had ever met, and then told her the details of her plan.

After a few hours of rest, Nightgale woke up surprisingly refreshed. She felt a delicious numbness, extremely relaxing. It wasn't just because she could get a break from Scarlet. She liked this form, even though she was getting tired of it more and more quickly. She suspected it was because of how stressful life had become for the Comrade General's right-hand . But now she felt happy. Her mother called her daughter, accepted her. Whatever they said about her… She didn't care. She may have committed countless crimes and hurt many innocents, but it didn't matter to her. She was her mother and nothing else mattered. She looked to the side and saw Aaravos looking at her thoughtfully. He smiled in his mysterious way and said.

„It always amazed me how easy it is to make mortals happy. It is enough to like you, or at least claim to like you, and joy wells up in your hearts”.

She frowned and said.

„It was acceptance... Accepting me into your family... Do you even accept me?”

The Star Elf tilted his head.

„Yes, in my own way.” he replied, and she felt a feeling of anxiety.

„What does "in my own way" mean?” she asked suspiciously.

„You don't want to know.” he replied, smiling indulgently.

„Now I definitely want to know. „ She drawled.

„Do you accept bots or, let's say, fish in the aquarium? Because that's how I see you... Although I must admit that you are a fascinating and exotic specimen...”

This strange, insulting compliment left her speechless. Well, she shouldn't expect anything less from beings like Aaravos or Lady Cala. She sighed and started her walk through the winding halls of Castle Crypto.

Several days passed during which they spoke little and never in private. Everyone was too busy preparing for Lonnie's plan, although she had the disturbing feeling that the Comrade General had made the decision to go ahead spontaneously, without thinking it through and without consulting her allies. But what could she do about it? Only on the eve of the marsh out did she find some time to exchange a few words with her. She found her mother in the courtyard, watching Lonnie inspecting the soldiers before they marched out. When she approached her mother, she asked her in Aklo.

„What do you think about all this?” she asked, and the Dark Sorcerer looked at her in surprise.

„About Lonnie's troops? They are impressive considering the conditions of Etheria... How do you know how to speak Aklo, it is the language of the Great Old Ones, Mi-Go, Elder Things and the like. It's not that easy to learn it here. Even I only learned how to use it fully when I left Etheria...”

She hesitated before answering. She wasn't sure if her mother should know about her connection with the Crawling Chaos… Certainly not now… She wanted her all to herself for the time being

„I had good teachers... „ she said, and the Dark Sorcerer just nodded. Nightgale's answer still said a lot about who she was hanging out with these days.

„When I have some free time, I will teach you how to mark your clothes so that you don't have to take them off every time you change.” Shadow Weaver said in a low voice. “It's such a popular technique in the galaxy that it's become part of every shapeshifting spell, but here, on Etheria, it's only taught in Mystacor. In fact, many people believe that taking off your clothes with every transformation is appropriate, because it brings you closer to nature... I never liked showing off my bare butt... Have you mastered any other shapes?”

She nodded hesitantly.

„ I've taken the form of a boar and a snake several times... I'm also thinking about a bird... „ she said, and Shadow Weaver nodded.

„Birds are difficult because in order to fly, you need to learn how to summon animal instinct in a safe way. I suggest to take shape the rat or raccoon, they will get everywhere... The cat is also good choice...„ she hesitated, as if she remembered something. Nightgale knew exactly what she was thinking about

„Catra and I met in this ancient city... She and Lonnie tried to kill each other, hence the scar... Adora was there too... I... I'm not sure if I should treat her like a sister?”

Shadow Weaver frowned.

„Everyone here is, in a sense, my and Hordak's children. We shaped them, or rather twisted them. In a way, Lonnie and the Rest is more our creation than Catra and Adora. They, despite my efforts, always had each other. Now I wonder if they didn't instinctively sense their origins... „ Her voice was thoughtful and careful, as if she was speaking out loud her thoughts that were just taking shape.

„Dr. Moors claims that he already suspected that Catra was not from Etheria...”

Her mother nodded.

„I heard about that after my return, even though I arranged for him to be transferred because he was too interested in Adora... I don't trust him, and neither should you. The Mi-Go only serve themselves, even the other beings from the Dark Between the Stars find space fungi treacherous and self-centered... Damn, they're like me... I wish we'd met earlier,' she laughed hoarsely.

„Don't say that... Don't compare yourself to them. – she said energetically, but Shadow Weaver shook her head.

„No my child. I may have shown you a little kindness, but it doesn't change who I am or what I've done. Once upon a time, I would have probably seen you as just a useful tool and used it to implement my plans... Or simply killed you in a fit of rage. That's who I was and that's how I am... Maybe it's a bit of a Castrovalian Paradox, but don't trust me... No one should... Over the last few years, I may have gotten used to everyone seeing me as a righteous and respectable person, but she never existed. Miss Daisy was a lie that I believed myself. A mask that I wore for so many years that I treated it like a second skin. All the lies finally come to light and the masks fall... „ she rubbed her face with her hand. „Look, maybe we can talk again before everything starts, but if not... Then take care of yourself and... remember not to go my way. You will have a difficult life, also because of me, but learn to appreciate the kindness you receive from others, respect those who care about you. Don't take other people's contempt personally, but don't let yourself be pushed around. It's just an old woman's talk, which doesn't cost her anything, but isn't of much value either. I lost my life because of my choices. Don't go my way...„ Shadow Weaver became thoughtful and asked. „Does anyone else know your secret?”

„Kyle and Frosta... But I know they won't say anything. O have a dirt on Kyle, and Frosta... She won't say anything. She's a good

girl.” she said. She preferred not to mention the cultists who knew everything, even predicted her mother's return.

„You're a good girl too, never forget that. And now I need to talk to someone. Watch out for Lonnie. He seems to be starting to suspect something. “ and left her alone with her thoughts.

Lonnie had to admit that she felt proud as she saw her soldiers getting ready to march. Most of them will not take part in the main mission, only in mock operations intended to distract the attention of Brightmoon's troops, so they will be convinced that he plans to strike somewhere other than in reality. She was proud of this part of the plan. No one should be harmed, her soldiers were not to engage in any fighting, only to cause confusion. A much smaller unit is to go to the capital and carry out the main part of the mission there. She was the one who was risky… much riskier than she thought she could be.

Previously, the only threats were Brightmoon's guards and the princesses, and neither of them would try to harm them unless they actually threatened them. But now that the Lord Admiral was in the capital... How many soldiers could he take with him? From what she said, Shadow Weaver was a real soldier who had been fighting wars for decades. She remembered all too well the days of the occupation, when they had to hide in canyons and caves from an enemy they could not fight. Will Glimmer's naive trust allow Etheria to fall into the clutches of an invader again? All this only confirmed her belief in the path she had chosen. She and her squad would go to Brightmoon armed with the gifts given to them by the Mi-Go, and she had the damned Shadow Weaver's warnings somewhere. This woman was always jealous of the power she could not control. She thought that as soon as she showed up on their doorstep, they would listen to her bullshit like before... The world has changed and they are no longer the same kids afraid of shadows. She looked at the dark Sorceress, thoughtfully surveying the lines of cadets. Scarlet was standing next to her, whispering in her ear every now and then. She

frowned at the sight. Since their conversation together, Shadow Weaver and the former Cadet have become closer. She didn't like it very much, but that included everything related to her former superior.

„Are they fucking or something?" she asked herself.

„She's not her type... „ she heard a voice behind her that she didn't recognize. She turned around, her hands gripping her amazing staff. Behind her stood Eti, her head resting on her shoulder and her tail wagging gently. She hadn't yet learned to recognize her voice, which was so different from Catra's. Lower, deeper, almost colorless. She stared at her with catlike eyes, blinking slowly.

„Can you not sneak up on me?" She asked, a little irritated, but not as much as she should have been. This girl didn't annoy her as much as Catra, she wasn't as mean and cunning, just weird.

„I could, Scar, but I think someone should keep you alert. If you always expect me to be lurking in the shadows, watching you even in your most intimate or embarrassing moments, your alertness will reach superhuman levels and even Ahackek's best Assassins won't catch you... And you'll fall into paranoia, but you can live with that... Somehow. Until you start to suspect your loved ones of plotting against you and you live in a cave with only bats and spiders for company, until you finally start to believe that you are one of them and then you either lie in wait in the web for your prey or you travel through the night sky in search of a victim from which you can drink the blood... Either way, it will be Blonde-boy... „ Eti said. She stared at the cat girl with her mouth open. She knew she must look really stupid, but she couldn't help it.

„What did you mean, he's not her type? " she asked, regaining her composure. „ Does she even have a type?"

„Sure.„ Eti tilted her head to the other side. "You didn't know? And you say you know her so well... Well, she likes blond,

muscular warriors with swords. We met her girlfriend in Brightmoon…”

Lonnie opened her mouth even wider.

„You're not suggesting ... that she and... „ she asked in disbelief. She shuddered at the thought.

„Well, I suggest that Grimmy is dating a Hellkightess” Who were you thinking about... Oh, the Blonde! No... It's a damn big age difference... Itel thinks she was into me, but it was about my sister, right?” she asked, and then Lonnie had the impression that the girl became strangely serious, although no emotions appeared on her face. – Okay, I'll leave you now, talk to your girlfriend.

„Scarlet is not my girlfriend... „ she replied, realizing that she was losing control of this conversation. – I have two boys!

„Kyle says you're sleeping with her... „ Eti protested.

„Once or twice... That doesn't make her my girlfriend. What kind of army would it be if everyone date with everyone else?” she asked, feeling a surge of irritation again

„Very lovely... Okay, I'm leaving now, bye.„ said the cat-like girl and ran between the shadows.

She wondered for a moment what this conversation was about, but came to the conclusion that she didn't have the strength to consider Eti's reasoning. Catra's sister was really weird. She didn't know if she could believe Eti's revelations about Shadow Weaver having a partner. The very idea that someone like the Cursed Sorceress could have sex with someone filled her with disgust and dismay. She didn't believe that she loved someone. This woman had a piece of basalt instead of a heart. But she still had no idea why the two sorceresses' relationships had changed so much. Now the thought of the two women being together seemed absurd to her, but what could have happened between them? Has Scarlet decided to form an alliance with someone stronger? Or was it Shadow Weaver who promised to share her dark secrets

with her? She wasn't sure, but she couldn't fully trust her old friend anymore... But had she ever really trusted her? She had to talk to her anyway. She waited until the Dark Sorcerer went about her business, and then she approached Scarlet.

„You shouldn't be so flirtatious with her. This woman is a natural manipulator who is ready to use anyone and then abandon them when they are no longer needed.” she said seriously, but the young Sorceress smiled at her.

„You sound like you're jealous.” she giggled quietly. She gritted her teeth and replied.

„I'm not jealous, I just don't trust her... You shouldn't either, out of common sense... She's never done anything for us, not selflessly ... She even served Hordak out of pure calculation.

„Probably out of necessity. Without Black Opal, she would have died in a very unpleasant way, if not worse.” said the Sorceress, this time much more seriously, without a trace of humor, absolutely seriously.

„Because she would turn into a vampire, or another character from the fairy tales she used to scare us as children... No, don't answer, I'm not going to start this ridiculous discussion... There's no point in you approaching her anyway. Remember our allies. Halo will definitely demand her head, and probably her sister's as well... Such allies are much more valuable than one treacherous Sorcerer” she said, barely holding back a scream. She wasn't about to lose her temper, but she had to talk some sense into the former cadet.

„Are you sure?” Scarlet asked carefully. ”This woman is incredibly powerful and knowledgeable. She has practically run the Horde for decades and could help us lead our Rebellion.

Narrowing her eyes, she drawled slowly at the scarlet-haired woman.

„Shadow Weaver is finished. She's a mean old woman who couldn't win a war for twenty-five years despite Hordak's technology and all her power. Her time has long passed. We'll keep her here for a while until she's no longer useful. Then we will give it to the highest bidder... Who knows, maybe Catra will join the bidding... And I would advise you to seriously consider who you owe your loyalty to.” she walked away feeling Scarlet's eyes on her back.

Nightgale sighed as she followed Lonnie, wondering how loyal she should be to Comrade General. Lonnie began to play a game whose rules she not only didn't understand, but wasn't even aware she was playing. The alliance with the Mi-Go was risky, but it could be profitable if you were careful, but Lonnie clearly had too much hope for working with the space fungi. She did it as if she wanted to convince herself that her decisions were right. She became more and more stubborn and stopped listening to others. The rest of rebelion were starting to notice it as well, though the arrival of Shadow Weaver distracted everyone from the problem a bit... But not for long... If she really wanted to do what she suspected... Then would the rest of the cadets continue to support her? Will her current allies, especially Star's sisters, turn on her? She ruled Dryll only with the consent of the inhabitants of this place, and if she gives the monsters from the Void Between the Stars their former ruler, they may change their minds. Then what? Will he fight the entire planet? And all this in exchange for what? For a ship she probably won't be able to handle? And even if she did, well, she was going to hand her mother over to her former enemies in order to maintain the alliance, though the young sorcerer suspected that the main reason she wanted to do this was because she felt threatened by the dark Sorceress… Perhaps rightly so. Shadow Weaver was powerful enough to take control of the rebellion and was competent enough to lead the rebellion to victory. But that wasn't her job. Both were to carry out the will of the Crawling Chaos. She even joined the Rebellion only because it could be used to implement Nyarlathotep's plans. It never really belonged to it. Not with the Heart... She was aware

that sooner or later she would have to abandon it. But she knew now that it wouldn't come easy. She became close with former cadets. She was surprised to find that Dryll, or rather Castle Crypto, had become her home. She was not attached to the ideals of the Rebellion, but to the people creating it. She felt sad at the thought of having to leave it all behind… But what could she do? No one could oppose the Will of the Crawling Chaos.

Kyle stood in one of the corridors of Castle Crypto and looked at his sword. He usually didn't like wandering inside the castle, it was too easy to get lost here. He did not have good spatial orientation, and even Entrapta herself had trouble finding her way in this labyrinth. He was slowly getting used to the idea that he had power! That he, Kyle, has power! It scared him, but it also made him happy that he could finally be useful to his friends. Especially now, when so many new threats have emerged. He had heard about this Lord Admiral, supposedly Catra's father, and that he was a very evil man. If he became this big guy, he could fight the Admiral just like Adora fought Hordak. Maybe they would even fight with together She-Ra against this tyrant. It would be nice to be a hero, even if he had to hide it from Lonnie. Yes, he will finally do something good and show that he can show his boyfriend and girlfriend that he deserves their love.

He didn't hear any footsteps. He had never heard them, not even in the Dread Zone. When she wanted, Shadow Weaver could move very quietly... like a shadow...

„Good Afternoon Kyle, I'd like to talk to you.” he heard a voice behind him that had terrified him for so many years. He jumped in fear and turned towards Hordak's former right-hand man.

„Oh, Shadow Weaver... How nice to see you. How can I help you?” He said, barely able to keep his legs from shaking. Shadow Weaver smiled sourly. Just the sight of her scarred face unnerved him, and that smile… Shadow Weaver had never smiled, and certainly not like this…

„You're still scared of me after all these years. I should consider it my success... But it only proves that I have failed... I have failed you all.” she said in a quiet, very tired voice

Now he was even more afraid. Shadow Weaver always scared him, but when she acted like this it was much worse. Over the years they had learned to avoid her wrath and had become very adept at it. But now that she was starting to behave differently, so unpredictably, he had no idea what could enrage her.

„Uh... If you say so. Who am I to question your judgment.” he said, and suddenly realized that it might be a trap and the woman might expect a completely different answer. “Uh, I mean I'm not criticizing you in any way.” he started to explain, but the Dark Sorcerer waved her hand and said.

„Don't explain yourself, Kyle. It's me who came to apologize to you... Do you remember that mouse you used to keep in a shoebox?” Shadow Weaver asked in a strangely uncertain voice…

„You're talking about Mr. Whiskers!„ he shouted and she looked at her warily. What was she getting at?

„That's what it was called... You see, at that time I was working on an experiment... I wanted to create a spell that would steal life and give it to me. However, I needed a subject to test the spell on, so at night I went to your quarters and took your mouse... Mr. Whiskers. Of course, the experiment didn't produce the expected results... and your pet died. You didn't notice me during the night, so when you woke up and realized the mouse was missing, you blamed Catra... I didn't mislead you... It wasn't because I was ashamed... I just didn't care. But now you know the truth and... I would like to ask you for forgiveness.”

Shadow Weaver stared at him as if she expected something from him, but he remained silent as his mind digested the Dark Sorceress's words… He finally burst out laughing. Loud and humorless, and Shadow Weaver stared at him in confusion. When he cooled down a bit, he started talking. The words came from

the depths of his heart, he couldn't... he didn't want to stop them, even though he was sure he would regret it.

You're apologizing to me now! After all these years, when it doesn't matter anymore? Do you even understand what you did? It's not about Mr. Whiskers, even though I loved him so much. Because of you, Lonnie and Rogelio almost beat Catra. We blamed her all these years. We wanted to hurt her then... Just like you hurt us all... It's not me you should be asking for forgiveness, but Catra... But she would never give it to you." he blinked twice because he just understood something. "That's who you meant, right? You wanted to see if we could forgive you, if she could forgive you if you just asked nicely. You just had to test it on someone. Preferably on nice, fearful Kyle... I'm like Mr. Mustache to you." he lowered his head and added. "Leave me alone!"

He narrowed his eyes, expecting a harsh and painful punishment... But instead, Shadow Weaver stared at him with an expressionless face, and then disappeared into the shadow from which she had emerged.

Final Corrects

Chapter Notes

> Here's the next chapter. I would love to hear your opinions because I don't know how many people read this.

„Well, I don't know, isn't it a bit too gold? I have the impression that if the light falls on it at the wrong angle, it will blind everyone.” she said, looking at the drawing of the wedding cake. “Is it real gold? Because then I would feel guilty going to the toilet.” she laughed nervously, but the cook, a tall snake person, looked at her disapprovingly and said

„No, it's pollen from the Solar flower of Eridani. In fact, it is more expensive than gold.”

„Er, it's probably even worse... And this cake is... Madly red...„ she said, pointing to another picture red as blood. The snake person nodded and said

„I was inspired by your fiancée's clothing style and her personality. It is stuffed with scarlet jam.”

:Er... Catra doesn't like jam very much... She'd rather like cream... „ he said carefully.

„But she would like this one. It is made from gelled blood. On Aquarius they consider it a real delicacy.”

She and Castaspella looked at him meaningfully, so the cook sighed and said with resignation.

„I thought that the heroes had broader horizons... I understand that you won't like the lamprey cake either. – as they gave him a murderous look, they sighed. – Maybe a lemon-almond cake, or a

naturally colored green coconut-pineapple cake… – he suggested in a resigned tone.

„Aww! Lemon and almond will be good... Although coconut sounds good too... Do you have anything nutty?” she asked, but seeing the anguish in the snake eyes she said. – Okay, let's have the lemon-almond one... Just add whipped cream... Catra loves it.” she said and the cook nodded.

„Ha! We've already taken care of choosing a wedding cake. It was quick, it took Glimmer over two hours because she wanted to try all of them... „ Castaspella said tiredly and yawned.

„Because no one haven't tried experimenting on her” she said in a low voice, looking sideways at the cook who was giving orders to his assistants. “What made me choose a cook from outside the palace?

„It was supposed to relieve the pressure on the palace kitchen... „ The Head Sorceress replied. “Besides, you wanted to present different flavors of the Universe and you assumed that someone who has been traveling around nearby planets for the last three years knows the cuisines of other worlds... which is actually true.” The queen's aunt smiled weakly.

She sighed and stretched her back. These wedding preparations will exhaust her. This was to be an event for all of Etheria. Or rather, the entire alliance... Empress Eridani assured that she would come to the ceremony to sign the pact. This gave Catra a lot of extra work, even though they couldn't see each other two days before the wedding... To miss each other... or something. Of course, it is the duty of future spouses to meet secretly. Scorpia and Perfuma met in extremely obvious disguises. Mermista and Seahawk dated on a boat at sea until they were late for their own wedding. Only Hordak and Entrapta didn't care about it, they stayed together all the time, they even performed the ceremony without any witnesses. Only they didn't have time for it. Empress Eridani was her most powerful and loyal ally. Catra thought of her as a stuck-up girl who stuck her nose up and pushed around

those inferior to her, but she and Glimmer were very fond of each other. Actually, she wasn't a bad person, but the inhabitants of Eridani were so different from the Etherians... Their nobility considered themselves superior to the ordinary inhabitants of the planet only because they were born with wings. They loved Glimmer and She-Ra and treated the other princesses nice, as well as Catra... But how would they treat the ordinary citizens of their planet who were used to much greater equality? What happens if one of them offends someone or worse, gets insulted? She couldn't handle interpersonal conflicts, and the situation seemed to be tense. It was good that Catra's father's subordinates obeyed him and did not cause any problems... But by their very arrival, they disturbed the peace of everyone who came to celebrate.

As soon as Glimmer announced publicly that guests from outside the Empire were going to attend the celebration, a fleet of ships appeared in orbit bringing soldiers and officers. This irritated Glimmer because it meant that the Lord Admiral was prepared for the Queen to agree to his request. However, this did not change the fact that once again foreign soldiers were walking through the streets of capitol, although they seemed to be completely unlike the troops of both Hordes. First of all, they were not a monolith as they expected. Most were members of the Lord Admiral's private fleet called the Fearless Armada. Some came from Tarak, the home planet of Lord Admiral and... Catra. Many, however, came from Other Planets, because they were recruited later, during all the wars that her future father-in-law participated in... She couldn't understand, like most of the inhabitants of Etheria, how someone could fight for money, but Catra with a grim smile explained to her, that she herself employed mercenaries from the Crimson Wastes when she returned from exile, although she hid this from Hordak. She had also seen dokuments that showed that Shadow Weaver had also hired thugs to perform tasks that the Horde leader would not like. Which often meant eliminating her rivals. Sometimes she forgot how complex life was in the Horde and what it took to survive… or maintain High Position. But she

still couldn't understand those who killed for money, even if it was just Hive monsters... Whatever they were.

„Adora! Adora! You won't believe who I met!!” she heard Swiftwind's voice as he stuck his head out the window. No one paid attention, apparently the castle cooks were used to the mount's visits. She smiled at her friend and said with a hint of amusement.

„If it's a dragon, I'll be really surprised… And thrilled”

„And I met a dragon a few days ago... Although it was very small. But just follow me! Quick!” Aricorn shouted.

„All right. Lead the way! Would it bother you, Castaspella, can I left you here for a while?” she asked the Head Sorceress who shrugged.

„You've already chosen the dress, and we'll arrange the guests at the tables in the afternoon... I've seen your sketches. They look very... strategic.„ she said. She didn't quite understand what Castaspella was talking about, these were very good plans. She spent half the night making them until Catra finally ordered Brother Blade to tell her to go to sleep.

„Well, see you in the afternoon.” She said, shouted "For the Honor of Grayskull" and jumped out of the window.

She had never seen anything so lovely. A choir of little furry creatures with six legs was singing on main plaza of Brightmoon, a solemn and beautiful song. She remembered that there was probably one of them on Queen Angela's crew, but the that one wanted to cut Perfuma into pieces. These were so sweet that even the mention of Glimmer's mother didn't make her sad. Swiftwind accompanied them by clapping... It mean, Swiftwind was tapping his hoof. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw that the creatures were being led by a large cat person with black fur. She remembered what Catra had told her and walked up to him.

„Sorry to disturb you, but you must be Pahtra?” she asked. The Cat person turned to her and put a strange white roll into his mouth and lit it on fire.

„Yeah.” he said in a low voice and blew stinking smoke towards them.

„Because Adora's girlfriend is also a Pahtra, at least a little bit so it would be nice to meet some of her people.” Swiftwind said enthusiastically. She told him a bit of Catra's Story the day before yesterday

„I see.” he took another drag and blew into them again. It was going to be a long conversation.

„Could you tell us what song they sing, because we liked it very much and...„ she said, hoping that this time she would receive a more precise answer. It was not Pahtra who gave it to her, but someone from behind her back.

“This is the anthem of Veskarium.”

She turned around and saw a large Lizard with half of its face covered in countless Scars.

„Oh! Hello! There's Adora She”Ra, Princess of Power, and this is my Brave Steed Swiftwind. – Aricon bowed low

„I am Zare... Commander-in-Chief of the Veskarian contingent.” she looked down at her. Even though she was in She”Ra's form, the lizard”man was almost as tall as her.

„Oh, and what is this anthem actually about?” she asked. Veska looked at the creatures and gave an order in a hard voice.

„Sing in common!”!

The creatures bowed to Zara and began the song again, this time in a language she understood.

“Invincible is Veskarium!

Her glory is eternal!

Her banners will fly in all corners of the galaxy.

The seas will turn red with the blood of her enemies!

The glow of burning cities will turn night into day!

Damoritosha's divine will leads us towards conquest.

The entire universe will kneel before the power of Veskarium... „ the melody and voices were as joyful as before.

„That's enough! – she exclaimed sharply and Vesk, with tears of emotion in her eyes, looked at her in surprise.

„You don't like our anthem? It contains the ideals that guide our people!” she said eagerly.

"It's a little too... Intense for my taste..." she laughed nervously, while Swiftwind, standing next to her, tapped a rhythm with his hoof unconsciously. “You know, I think my old friend Rogelio was someone like you. – she said, hoping to change the topic of conversation to something less... disturbing.

„So he was a Vesk. It is a great tragedy that he could not grow up in the warm embrace of Veskarium. He would then be taught to fight with all weapons from childhood. We would instill in him love for our great country and contempt for its enemies. He would look forward to the day when he would stand in the front lines fighting for the glory of Veskarium, fearing nothing, because there is no greater honor than a glorious death for one's motherland!” there was a fiery passion in the lizard woman's voice.

„You know, I have the impression that he probably didn't miss much.” she smiled at her interlocutor, trying not to reveal the terror hidden in her heart. Zare snorted with contempt and was

about to say something more when another person approached them and joined the conversation.

„Our... friends from Veskarium can be... intense sometimes, but I assure you, not all of them are like that. I once had a girlfriend, Vesk. She loved music and sang love songs about broken hearts so wonderfully!" another lizardman explained. She looked completely different. She was even bigger than Zare, although not as muscular. It had a long neck and wings on its back, and its scales were silver. Zare snorted again.

„The only thing that can break a true Vesk's heart is the cowardice of his companions!"

„Oh! I've met someone like you before! Swiftwind joined in the conversation. – Remember how I told you that I met a dragon! This was someone like that!" her mount exclaimed enthusiastically. The silver-scaled lizardman smiled surprisingly friendly, even though it revealed a multitude of sharp fangs.

„I am not a Dragon, but a Dragonkin. This is quite a common and absolutely understandable mistake. However, there are many dragons on our home planet, Tiraxus, just like in other parts of the galaxy... And my name is Tares, and I represent the Pact Worlds in this endeavor.„ said Tares. Swiftwind looked at his mistress pleadingly. She smiled and stroked his head.

"Don't worry, I will never replace you! You are the most wonderful steed anyone could imagine."

„Oh, most dragons would react very badly to the idea of being someone's mount. They are powerful and proud Beings... And you said you've ever met someone like me?"

Somewhat reassured, Aricorn nodded and said.

„Yes! He was also silver and said his name was Alatar and… Did something happen?" asked Swiftwind, seeing that the dragonkin looked sad.

„Nothing like that... I used to have a nephew with that name, but I lost him when Kesler was devoured by the Swarm”

She stretched and yawned. She dozed for an hour, basking in the moonlight, lying on a soft couch on the balcony, listening to the sound of the waterfall. It put her to sleep, made her feel relaxed... Her only regret was that Adora wasn't with her... preferably naked. Unfortunately, due to this stupid custom, she couldn't officially meet her beloved... On the other hand, he can simply sneak up on her at night. This will be too easy. It would be funnier if Adora sneaked up on her at night, preferably in the form of She-Ra. She used to feel strangely around her girlfriend's second form, but now she discovered that she had many advantages...

„Grand Marshal Catra! Lord Admiral Felix Antares…. I mean, your father... wants to see you!” Brother Blade shouted. She groaned and said with resignation in her voice.

„Okay, tell him I'm on my way.”

Her father was waiting for her in the garden. He was alone, Lady. Ka was busy with her work, she wasn't sure what it was, but it must have involved various unpleasant things. The woman's absence didn't bother her in the slightest. She reminded her too much of Shadow Weaver. Next to my father stood two soldiers in full gear and a self-propelled cart covered with a plank

„Hey, Lord Admiral.„ she said. She still couldn't bring herself to call him father, but he didn't push her, and she was grateful... She couldn't think of herself as someone with a family. This should have happened to Adora. She would be happy to meet her parents. She too. Adora's parents certainly wouldn't be so... domineering. They would rather be nice and goofy.

„I would like to show you the wedding gift I prepared for your fiancée.” her father said and ripped off the sheet with a strong

pull. Armor appeared before her eyes. It was golden white, the colors of She-Ra'y. It seemed large and heavy, but she had seen armor like that on clones, and Hordak wore a similar one as well. They were called power armor. It provided the user with greatly increased strength and speed, which in Adora's case meant… Uh, truly tremendous strength and speed. She touched one shoulder pad gently. It turned out to be surprisingly light.

„I have two such armors. I wear one in battle, and the other is for my heir. However, you don't like wearing heavy armor, so I decided to give it to Adora. It took some time to give it She-Ra's colors."

She touched the armor with sincere and unconcealed delight. She had to admit he was beautiful. She gently ran her finger across its surface. Not even a scratch was created, even though they cut the armored steel

„What is it made of?" she asked in a quiet voice, and the Lord Admiral replied proudly.

„It's Adamant. One of the strongest metals. And the rarest ones. Some ships are built from the alloy, but it is almost pure metal. Nothing can it. Adamant is called the bones of the gods."

She grimaced when she heard the term

„We're talking about all these gods again. Are they really that important to all of you? Do you seriously believe in them?"

Antares frowned.

„It's not a matter of faith, but of common sense. Gods exist, that is an indisputable fact. It's good to have them on your side and it's better not to irritate them." her father said, and in response she laughed darkly.

„So they are like Shadow Weaver. We were afraid of her and constantly wanted to please her. Does this mean that we should build an altar for her too?"

Her father looked thoughtful. Then he said in a gentle, warm, fatherly voice.

„I know that a lot of bad things have happened to you in your life and it almost broke you, but you found the strength to overcome your inner darkness and became a true hero. However, there are millions of children in the Empire who must live in conditions undreamed of by most of the inhabitants of Etheria, except for children of war like you and your fiancée. I intend to end this, and as soon as the celebrations ends, I intend to leave to fight the Inheritors of Horde Prime. I would like to ask you, my daughter, to come with me and help me fight this war. Of course, Adora is also invited, her presence will certainly help significantly in defeating our enemies."

She looked at her father in pure astonishment. He suggested that she go with him to wage war against the Ultimate Horde and the Celestial Brothers. She would have to give up her position as Grand Marshal and leave Etheria for many months, maybe even years... But after all, weren't they going to do that anyway? That's why Glimmer wanted her to get closer to her father. Now she had the opportunity to really help the alliance. And he will command a real modern army...

„I'll think about it... What do you have for me? – she asked, smiling at Antares. She wanted to jokingly change the subject, but her father took her words with absolute seriousness.

„Everything" he replied in a solemn voice. "You are my heiress. You will receive everything I have."

Only after a long moment did she understand the meaning of his words. She felt happy... and scared, it's hard to say which was stronger.

Calamity was aware that over the past few days she had not come much closer to achieving their great mission. She was preoccupied

with other matters. She was looking for an opportunity to... bypass the agreement made between Creeping Chaos and Shadow Weaver, but so far she had not found any loophole, no possibility of bending the rules, it was dangerous She knew that playing with Nyarlathotep's will was not the best idea, nor was trying to abuse their patience. Her only success so far was winning the favor of the Lord Admiral. She guessed that this man was planning to make Catra his right hand, his successor. Although she would prefer to see her in many small pieces, but if this man is as much of a monster as he is said to be... This could cause Catra to fall again, and this time the girl will sink completely into darkness without even realizing it. Perhaps such a fate would be much fairer than even the most painful death.

However, it pained her to admit that she missed Shadow Weaver. Unfortunately, she failed to fully gain the favor of the people of Etheri. Yes, they had well-deserved admiration for her and she aroused great interest, but she did not earn their trust. It was largely the fault of her temperament. The training fight with the hellknight really spoiled her relationship with Adora, who, despite her astonishing pace, noticed that the fight was getting out of control. To make matters worse, the Dark Sorceress' lover wielded that damedd sword. She already knew about his existence, but she didn't expect that she would come face to face with the warrior of hell. She didn't know what power this blade had, but the possibility that it could prematurely end her precious life was outrageous. She unnecessarily made an enemy of both people who posed a real threat to her. If Shadow Weaver were here, it would be easier for her to predict the consequences of her actions.

What was done was done, now she was starting to implement their actual plan. Even the inhabitants of Brightmoon were unaware of the vastness of the underground beneath the castle. They extended to the nearby mountains, and more importantly, they were the work of the First Ones. Courtesy of Heart Gift, she had a map of the entire area. She was now going to meet with the silly AI and confirm the information she had acquired. The Queen accepted the Bloodstone fragment, and this Entrapta was

stupid enough to be easily tricked into installing it. Shadow Weaver had no idea about this part of the plan. If all goes well, then, by the will of the Creeping Chaos, he will gain access to Etheria's energy grid, and then...

„Hello Heart Gift. I came to visit you, just like I promised!” she exclaimed in the nicest voice she could muster. Heart Gift immediately materialized.

„Oh! Lady Cala! So nice to see you! I knew you wouldn't lie to me!” the AI shouted happily.

„I would never cheat on my friend. Could you show me again the map you showed me before?”

Heart Gift nodded and brought up the map. Calamity studied the map for a few minutes. The most promising point was in the nearby mountains, quite close to where she was currently. Suddenly a great idea occurred to her.

„Could you create a guard like the one I met before?”

The AI nodded cautiously and said.

„I guess so, but why would I do that?

„Because enemies will approach. Enemies of the First Ones. I wouldn't want something bad to happen to my friend.” she said with concern in her voice. Heart Gift She nodded in understanding. Well, if that AI kills Adora, doesn't he break the contract? She smiled cruelly.

Planning and Preparations

Chapter Notes

> Here's the next chapter. The scam is real. I invite you to comment and ask for feedback.

„Please. Here are your new glasses.” said the Rebel soldier named Sune, smiling friendly to them. “I don't know if they will be as good as yours, we don't have such good technology here as yours, but we did everything we could. We installed something similar in your helmet. It's a pity we didn't have this in the past, because we had a deaf girl here and she had to leave because she couldn't hear what was being said to her. Although maybe it's better. She was finally adopted... I wonder what's happening to her now? I would like to meet her someday.” concluded the soldier and they left to take care of his own business. Their scuad stood outside their ship, waiting to depart. Eti stood next to Sparkling Paw, who smiled cheerfully at everyone and tried to say something.

„Do I sound similar?” she looked questioningly. Itel slowly nodded her head, and Alatar and Lilka made the okay sign.

„Roughly so... They didn't hear your voice much, but they did a very good job.” said Eti. Sparklepaw's voice was a little deeper, a little more mature. Ita was more feminine... She liked it.

„Thanks. It's nice to understand what others are saying to you and to be understood... I mean, Eti understood me, but it's nice to talk to others... I'm not saying it's bad to talk to Eti, but now I can talk to everyone.” said the white-haired girl, blushing. Itel approached her, and slowly, so that Sparklepaw noticed.

„I'm also happy to talk to you, Rosie... „ The elf said and smiled sadly, but in a friendly way. The shooter understood that it was

mostly her fault. They weren't together with Itel, but actually they were… Why were the feelings so complicated? The fight was easier. You would target someone, press the trigger and someone would go to sleep. And emotions... Nothing was easy with them. They were like fire, untamed and impossible to control. They warmed the soul, but could easily burn it, leaving scars that could not be healed, or even completely consumed it, leaving only ashes... She regretted that she had hurt her friend. Itel didn't deserve what happened to her, but not that she "broke up" with her. In fact, she should have done it already, she unnecessarily allowed the elf to delude herself that there could be something between them. They were friends, Itel was one of the first people she met after she was freed from Jantar and Lady Ka. They cared about each other. Together they risked their lives and fought against those who stood in their way. But she couldn't give her her heart, because Itel's heart actually belonged to her hatred. Anger pierced her through and through, like a hunter's pike piercing a wild beast. She should help her friend heal these wounds, but she had no idea how. She should ask Sparklepaw, she knew about feelings, but she was part of the problem.

Sparklepaw… Rosie… She didn't know how to describe how she felt about her. She liked her very much. She wanted to stay with her as long as possible. Watch her smile full of joy. Smelling her scent, touch her skin. Kiss me. Yes! She would like to kiss her and even more! She would like to see her without clothes. Touch her. Make love to her. She has always liked girls and only girls. In addition to Itel, she slept with several Others, such as the daughter of Doctor Sidonius . But she had never felt with anyone what she felt with Rosie. Did she love her? Could someone like her love a monster, someone? She was an Assassin , a murderess created to kill and enslave those too weak to resist her will. She was the daughter of a tyrant, a monster who had the lives of millions of beings on his conscience. What was worst of all, she was not only his daughter, but someone, or something, created in his image, just like this Catra. Only the other one didn't know the truth. The Lord Admiral was a skillful manipulator who deceived millions . Will he be able to do it with that girl? Will she become a

puppet dancing to his tune or will she be like a fly in a spider's web? Or maybe she won't care at all. She heard the whispers of the Rebels and felt their eyes on her. She saw anxiety, fear, and sometimes hostility in them. Her sister was raised in Horde, in military barracks, trained from childhood to be an ideal soldier, under the supervision of Grimmy. There was a secret in it that no one wanted to tell her, or maybe she was afraid to find out because the truth might be too painful to accept. Since childhood, he was best friends with the Blonde, Adora , who had the power to become this Big Girl. and then everything changed. Her sister became Hordak's right hand and led the war until she was kidnapped by Crooked Face and there something terrible happened to her, although from what she understood, she had already suffered a lot before... But now she wants to marry this cool Blonde. Only for reasons she didn't understand, Scar wanted to fight her. Actually , she liked the Scar. There was the same fierceness in her as Itel... Maybe she should hook up with the Elf? She had two boyfriends ... but she also liked girls, and Itel liked boys, so why not the four of them can live together?. The blond guy was very nice. He reminded her a little of her sister's fiancée and a little of Sparklepaw. It's hard to say why. Maybe because he was nice and had this weird sword…

„Hello... „ she heard the timid one and Blonde Boy came out from between the buildings... I'm talking about the basilisk.

„Hey Blonde Boy. What's up? Are you coming with us?” she asked, and Sparkypaw added.

„I can now speak in a way that you can understand me. I will tell you about Absalom ! This is a wonderful place! „ „ the former intern liked Blonde Boy very much, although in a quite innocent way. Well, they were both similar. Seemingly charming and delicate, but deep down they are as hard as Tempered Steel. Upon seeing him, Toshi squealed and flew to the boy. He liked him too. Alatar, Itel, and Lilka greeted him as well, though the red-haired girl tried to look down at him like a seasoned orc warrior would a young one, even before the "Great Test" or whatever she

thought orcs did. Considering that Blonda was over a head taller than Lilka, it was quite a feat..

„Well, that's what I'm wondering about. We haven't been getting along very well with Lonnie lately, but Rogelio keep Eye on her... and for Scarlet. I'd like to talk to you for a moment. And then I'll see... And Itel, Lonnie wants to talk to you.” he said, and the Elf nodded and went to talk to Scar. "Aha, so something is brewing..." She thought with satisfaction. When they were alone, Blonde Boy looked around as if he wanted to know if no one wanted was listening to them and asked

„Eti, could we talk about your sister for a moment?” he looked down.

„But what should we talk about? Now I know everything.” she exclaimed, looking at her metal hand . There was a strange, anxious tension all around.

„No, you don't know everything. You must know the truth... „ he whispered and began to tell her the story of her sister and her life in the Horde.

Itel knew she should feel honored to be invited by the Comrade General. She respected this woman. She accomplished what she will never be able to do. She led the uprising against tyranny... Well, it wasn't actually tyranny and the uprising was not supported by the inhabitants of the planet... She guess that was the problem... She had no idea that she would get them into such a mess cursed by devils and demons. It wasn't Rosie's fault. How could the girl know that Antares was such a bastard. Millions believed in his nobility, why would an intern who didn't know her true name think otherwise. It was her companions who hid the truth from her, even Dilayla, who seemed to be trustworthy. Besides, there was no way they could prevent the Lord Admiral from arriving on this planet. Catra was the main reason he was here.

It wasn't Shadow Weaver's fault either. The Dark Sorceress did what seemed best at the time... And perhaps it was. The People's Rebellion was the safest place for them to hide from the Father of the two cat girls at the moment. No, she was to blame for everything. If she hadn't come up with the idea of breaking into the castle, they would have been able to roam the planet freely as long as they were careful, gathering allies and warning others about the Lord Admiral. She had burned all the bridges behind them and they had to take shelter here... But what could they do now? They didn't know how much Catra and the rest of the queen's court trusted Antares , and according to Scarlet's words, they treated him with cautious kindness, but that was a few days ago, and Antares was a patient man who was able to bend to his will with perseverance and built his legend perfectly. Has he already managed to convince everyone that he is the hero they have always been waiting for? The father she always dreamed of. They must enlist the help of Lonnie and her rebels, although they had no idea what the General was actually planning. Now maybe she'll learn something.

They were in the command room. Scarlet, Shadow Weaver, Lonnie, and her officers were here . She recognized Grizzol , and the others introduced themselves as Cobalt , Octavia. Sune, the head of the technicians, and Doctor Moors were also there, although no one wanted to be near the Brain in the Cylinder, which she wasn't surprised at all, because even she, a girl who had experienced the horror of a Swarm invasion, was terrified by this individual. In addition to them, there was Lonnie and Kyle's boyfriend named Rogelio, two guards in expensive armor, and a creature called the Imp, who looked a bit like the smallest of the devils, but upon closer inspection she decided that he was more clone than hellspawn. As everyone sat down, she was surprised to see that everyone, even Dr. Moors, was staring at her with curiosity mixed with suspicion. It was a surprisingly embarrassing feeling. She may not have had social anxiety like Eti, but being the center of attention was very embarrassing .

„Well, now that we're gathered here, it's time to discuss our plan.” Lonnie said and began to describe their plan. Most of the rebels

were to carry out mock attacks on border posts and government buildings. Nothing really serious, just a few simple acts of vandalism, without getting into a fight with the princesses' forces. This way they could distract Catra and reassure her that Brihghtmoon was safe while the rest of them were supposed to attack the party, where some of them were supposed to cause a ruckus and announce the formation of the People's Alliance, while the other group was supposed to get into the castle to break into castle database, install a worm there, which she herself suggested, because the Rebellion members' knowledge of computers was limited and... There were differences of opinion what nex. Lonnie insisted on the idea of kidnapping Entrapta, the former Lady of the castle they were staying in and a brilliant inventor, in which Doctor Moors supported her, and Shadow Weaver opposed it with Scarlet's support. The Dark Sorceress intended to meet with Hordak, the former leader of the Horde and husband of Entrapta , and a few of her other allies, whose names she did not provide. She wanted to warn them about the Lord Admiral and other threats of the Galaxy, but she wasn't going to reveal exactly what she wanted to talk to them about. No one was going to take sides in this discussion. No one here liked or trusted Shadow Weaver, but from what she could see, the Brain in the Cylinder didn't have much sympathy of the Rebel either. She herself had to admit reluctantly that she liked the idea of a gloomy Elf better. She understood that the greatest threat to everyone was the Lord Admiral and kidnapping some princess was a waste of time. At first she didn't speak, watching the argument, but eventually she decided that this meeting would never end, so she spoke up.

„Maybe we'll steal the sword. You know, the magical one that allows Adora to become this big girl with a sword. Apparently she gained power when she found him, so if we take him, then... „ she said, convinced that she had come up with a brilliant plan that would reconcile everyone and solve the problems, but when everyone looked at her and in the eyes of many of them she saw lenient interest, she felt that the beginning of brown.

„Adora used to need a sword to become She-Ra, but now she no longer needs it, she uses it. She broke it the moment the heart was activated. Now she can become her without his help.” Lonnie explained with a hint of impatience in her voice.

She's heard this story before from this Aricorn Swiftwind , but she didn't believe him. The rest, however, accepted it as true.

„And even if they did, well, only the First Ones could activate it, and I don't think anyone here knows any other representative of this ancient civilization, unless I don't know something. „ said Doctor Moors , and she had the impression that he was alluding to something, but what? Is he implying that Rosie was of this species? This idea was both ridiculous and disturbing.

„It's actually not such a stupid idea.” Scarlet interjected. “The sword is still kept in Brightmoon and is treated as a Kingdom Treasure, a priceless souvenir whose loss can have great symbolic significance. Besides, it's still a powerful artifact of the First Ones. Even if it has been cracked, it may hold many secrets that are still not known.”

„Didn't Entrapta examine him thoroughly?” Lonnie asked with surprise in her voice, and the younger sorceress shook her head.

„Adora told Entrapta not to examine him, but she didn't insist on her opinion. They are both too aware of potential threats... „ she said in a thoughtful tone and looked at Doctor Moors . “Would our allies be willing to examine it?”

The brain in the Cylinder thought for a moment, then spoke carefully.

„Yes, it will definitely interest them. I even think that the knowledge they would gain from it would enable them to launch a certain ship hidden among the ice... „ he said, and she had the impression that some invisible exchange of words had taken place between him and Lonnie.

„Giving such an Artifact to Mi-Go is not a good idea. Shadow Weaver said sharply. Lonnie looked at the Dark Sorceress and spoke to her in a soft, thoughtful voice, without the anger and irritation usually heard when she spoke to a disfigured woman.

„This is still the best possible solution. All the alternatives... It doesn't matter... Itel, what do we have to be prepared for when it comes to the Lord Admiral?”

Only after a moment did she realize that it was her that the General had addressed and she blushed again. 'Do they take me for an expert on the Lord Admiral...' she thought and realized that they were actually right. She had been collecting information about this man for years and knew more about him than many statesmen and stateswoman who proudly called themselves the nation's chosen ones. She felt a sudden surge of confidence and began to tell all she know.

„He is ruthless, he will do anything to achieve his goals, but he is also cunning. He cares about public opinion... Because, you understand, he's not like your Horde Prime, in the galaxy you can't attack someone like that without a reason, especially if you're not as powerful as Azlanti or the Swarm. His army, at least the main part, is very disciplined and serves him faithfully, for which he repays them by paying them well and protecting them from the justice system and all enemies. The most dangerous are the Void Orphans. They are orphans raised by a fleet, mainly of wars with the Swarm” she looked at those gathered in the council hall and understood that for these former cadets or those who commanded them, what she said had special meaning. „There are still his jackals. These are bandits and murderers released from prisons, whom he rules with an iron fist and uses them as cannon fodder or to do dirty work... It was once commanded by an Elf, but Uncle Eti killed him and now they are probably commanded by Lady Ka, a Jantar clone just like Bina, the woman who took care of us… „ she mused darkly, because they had not heard from her since they left the wasteland. They didn't know if he was alive or in the hands of that monster Antares and her fucked up sister. She had been unkind to her lately, she didn't listen to her orders and

commands, even though she only cared about them... „Besides, you can expect absolutely anything.” She continued for a long moment of gloomy silence. – Cyber Ghouls, Vesks, Rogelio's crazy relatives, war mages, Drow assassins and dragons... One dragon, a gigantic and ancient red wyrm named Lady Sorrowflame, serves the Lord Admiral.” she sighed and drank some water. Everyone thought about her words for a few moments, and then a tall boy with blue hair walked into the command room and said a few words in her ear, and Lonnie smiled.

„The Empress of Eridani comes to Etheria. If we manage to kidnap her, we will force Glimmer to negotiate and make concessions. Listen, this is the plan. – Comrade General looked truly happy for the first time since she met her.

„What happened to us Emily.” he said to his friend and the Droid chirped in response. He smiled at her and added. “You know, it turns out Shadow Weaver is alive, Catra and Eti have a father, Rosie can throw tanks, and we joined the Rebellion. What happened to us.” he smiled, although he didn't feel happy. For the first time in the many years since he had been freed, he felt completely helpless. He felt like everything was getting out of his hands. When they landed on Etheria, he was sure that he would make everyone happy with good news. About the fact that Glimmer's mother is alive, that Catra has a sister, that he met Mara's descendant and that the galaxy not only has not been ravaged by the Horde, but is also full of beauty. And now he was traveling with the most hated woman on the planet, who was once again taking care of a group of kids, not only Bina’s one’s , but also her former cadets. He didn't say why these young people did not want to enjoy peace, but continued to fight against those who saved their world. But he has to be here, he won't let them get hurt, not again. While he was there, most of the former cadets ignored him, and then they started looking at him closely and suspiciously, as if he was up to something... It would be ridiculous if it weren't so sad... And problematic. It made it difficult for him to get close to them, and without it, keeping them

safe wouldn't be easy. At first he inspected the ship, as the young crew members were now busy and distracted, but it didn't take long, especially since Mr. Ilemshaw was helping him with it. Then he tried to help the former cadets, but they didn't trust him and wouldn't let him help them until Lilka intervened. Bina's wards were held in begrudging respect, probably due to their familiarity with Shadow Weaver, so when the red-haired girl invited him into the kitchen, no one stopped her. She took a few buckets of peeled potatoes and said that now she would prepare a real Ork potato cake for everyone. He had no idea that Orcs ate cakes or potatoes in general, but he didn't know much about Orcs at all, having never met one before. Lilka ordered the potatoes to be peeled and boiled, and then they mashed them with onion and bacon. Then she put the whole mass into several huge cake tins, an inheritance from Entrapta's ancestors, and ordered them to bake. When everything was almost ready, she ordered them to be taken out and placed on top of the crispy, goat cheese and minced meat, and then baked again for a while. The dish was delicious, tender on the inside and crispy on the outside. Everyone liked it, so no one protested when Lilka declared that she would bake a real orc cheesecake and appointed him her assistant. He liked cooking, although he didn't have many opportunities to do so, so he happily agreed. Thanks to this, no one protested when he volunteered to participate in the mission. He was currently standing next to the warehouse in a rebel outfit made especially for him.

„Listen Emily... I think you should stay here.” he said, and the Droid began chirping indignantly. “I know you can handle it. You've handled worse situations, but... I think you're being too conspicuous. There is no other Horde droids like this, in fact I haven't seen any other droid in Brightmoon. Besides, it's good to have someone waiting for us here.„ He said and hugged his friend, he hoped it wasn't goodbye.

As he walked towards the ship, he encountered Itel also heading towards him. The elf looked happy, which made him happy. After the fight with Itel and the breakup with Eti, in fact he didn't even

know that the girls were together, she was very depressed and he was starting to worry about her, but recently they reconciled.

„You know, Wrongdak, you don't have to participate in this mission. I know you will fight against your old friends. I don't quite understand why I'm taking part in all this.” she said and he shook his head.

„No... I should be with you. You saved me, even though you actually gained nothing from it. Now I have to protect you as best I can.” he said in a serious voice, and the Elf asked.

„From the Lord Admiral's men or from her.”

His only response was a sad smile.

When they reached the ship, they found that Kyle was already waiting for them. The boy was serious and looked a bit guilty. Itel frowned, but smiled at him and said.

„You're coming with us, just like Lonnie, Rogelio , Imp and Miss... Shadow Weaver.”

The boy nodded as if he didn't care much about the mission. He just sighed and said.

„Eti wants to talk to you.”

The elf looked concerned.

„Has something happened to Et?” There was fear in her voice.

„ Nothing at all and a lot. Kyle said and looked down.

They headed towards the cat girl's cabin. Eti was sitting on the bed, stroking Tonshi and looking ahead. She seemed strangely thoughtful, even distressed.

„Eti... Has something happened?” Itel asked, even more scared than before. The cat girl ignored her and asked, her voice duller than usual.

„Is this all true? About my sister and Grimy ... Shadow Weaver... About how she treated her... „ she looked at him.

„I didn't know her then. They set me free at the end of the war, and I only know what I was told. But yes, she hurt her a lot and everything that boy said is true.”

The girl let out a short, broken laugh.

„You know, I can't even hate her for it. The part of me, the part that burns cold, is even glad that someone had a life as fucked up as I did. Shadow Weaver was Catra's Lady Ka, or Lady. Ka was my Shadow Weaver... I can't hate her because she hates herself... Did you say yes? – she said to Itel, who blinked twice.

„What?” she asked , and the cat girl explained.

„Well, for Scar mariage proposal.”

The elf laughed and nudged Eti, and the atmosphere lightened a bit, but he knew enough about emotions to know that it wouldn't end that easily.

Masquerade

Chapter Notes

Here's the next chapter. I invite you to comment and express your opinion.

Tirin smiled to herself because it was easier than she expected. This place was unlike any other she had ever seen. It was beautiful here, like the fairy tales about the Old Empire that her mother used to read to her. Except it was real! A beautiful castle made of white and pink stone. Clean and tidy houses. Nice and friendly residents. The latter made her mission much easier. When she arrived here in a roundabout way, hiring transport from several different places, no one stopped her or questioned her. She had heard that on many planets, especially the Pact Worlds, the inhabitants enjoyed similar freedom, but she doubted that even there they welcomed travelers so warmly. She was a stranger girl from an unknown place wearing strange armor that no one here had probably seen before. Some, especially the drivers, guessed that she was a disabled person, but they didn't ask many questions. They felt sorry for her, but without overbearing pity, and respected her privacy, although they were probably curious about who she was and what happened to her. It was she who told her own story, made up of course. She was supposed to come from a distant planet attacked by the Horde. Her parents fled to a planet called Jadehell, thinking that Prime's forces would not reach there, no matter how dangerous the place was. Her mother died and she became ill. Shortly afterwards, the war ended and her depressed and sick father left her in the care of his friend, a rebel, who bought her this outfit. The story sounded credible and was as close to the truth as possible. Everyone nodded understandingly and didn't ask for more. She felt a bit guilty deceiving such nice people, but in her life she had often manipulated others for the greater good. No, it was not the

inhabitants of Etheria that were the biggest obstacle she encountered, but herself…

She had to take a double dose of anti-anxiety medication, but she still felt terrified. Her heart was pounding and she felt like she was going to die, or maybe she wanted to die a little, just to not be afraid. She kept asking herself how she could have been so stupid as to willingly agree to go on this expedition. Then she remembered that she was doing it for Captain Moonshadow, a woman who had done more for her than a birth mother, she had to help her. Therefore, she gritted her teeth and walked forward with her head down. When asked why she was acting so strangely, she simply told the truth. She claimed that a terrible accident had befallen her and now the sight of the open sky frightens her. They understood it, because the inhabitants of this place also suffered a lot from the Horde. Of course, she is one of those who oppressed and occupied, but she couldn't tell anyone that.

Brightmoon was full of visitors not only from all over Etheria, but also from other nearby planets. Everyone came here for the Victory Day celebrations and the Royal Wedding. She even received a leaflet describing the celebration. There was even a photo of happy couples. She stared at it for several long moments, oblivious to the terror hanging over her head. She saw both girls there. First she looked at the blonde traitor who was about to take over the Captain's sword. Was she really that bad? She seemed nice, maybe a bit lost, but truth be told, she didn't understand people very well. Apparently she was friends with the Queen, whose mother she was supposed to have betrayed. Maybe it was all just one big mistake, or maybe both girls were calculating schemers who had fooled everyone The latter possibility did not seem likely to her, but she was Azlanti, conspiracies and intrigues were in her blood. And the Captain's daughter... As she looked at her, she felt a twinge of jealousy, childish and stupid, but irresistible nonetheless. Glimmer was so beautiful... and healthy... She was the strong woman any mother would dream of, not the twisted and crippled wreck that she was. Will Moonshadow ever reconcile with his daughter, or will he

forget about Tirin? Will she reject her like the society of her race? And she will be alone again. A crippled girl in a great indifferent universe.

„Can I help you with something?” asked a man about sixty years old in a lilac coat and with a mystic's staff in his hand. She hastily put the leaflet in her pocket, glad that the mask made it impossible to see how she was blushing.

„No... It's just... I just arrived on Etheria and... I've never been to an event like this, so I feel a bit overwhelmed, especially since I am afraid of open spaces and crowds...„ she said hurriedly, and the man looked at her understandingly and said.

„I understand you a little. For some time I couldn't get used to the open sky and the stars. I'm Mikah and I can show you around the city.„ He said and smiled friendly. She hesitated, because her profession as a pirate taught her not to trust anyone... Although perhaps she owes it to her Azlantean upbringing... But she needed help, it would be difficult for her to get all the information she needed by tomorrow. Besides, the man seemed nice, so she could probably trust him.

„Nice to meet you Mikah , I'm Tirin... „ she extended her hand in bionic armor and Mikah shook it and asked.

„You have an unusual accent. I don't know him, but I've heard a lot of them because of my profession.”

„It's an Azlantean accent.” she replied and immediately bit her tongue. But she calmed down right after. After all, no one here has heard of the Azlanti Star Empire?

The years he spent on Beast Island taught him how to control his emotions, so he didn't show anything when the girl admitted that she was Azlanti. She probably only told him about it because she didn't think anyone on the planet would know what she was talking about. However, he knew who the Azlantii were, Shadow

Weaver herself had told him, and he decided to trust her on this one matter. These people imprisoned his wife, a noble and absolutely innocent woman who did not deserve such a fate. He took a deep breath to control the fire burning in his heart. The girl looked strange. She had navy blue, translucent hair and extremely pale skin, and her eyes were completely purple, even the whites. She wore an oxygen mask over her face and was clad in a strange armor that looked like it was made of organic matter. She seemed petite and looked unhealthy. She must have been ill with something serious. She also seemed afraid, even afraid to look around. It was understandable, after all, she had come here on a mission from her superiors. She was probably supposed to be spying on Brightmoon before the attack or something. Except... She didn't look like the kind of person who would conspire against his daughter, but appearances can be deceiving. Moreover, not all servants of the forces of evil are bad and wicked people. Just look at Scorpia , who was an extremely nice and sympathetic woman, and yet she served the Horde faithfully for years and tried to kill Bow several times . Maybe it was similar with this girl? She was just an innocent cog in a terrible machine of terror and exploitation. She could also be a skillful manipulator who perfidiously exploited the mercy and kindness of others, someone like Shadow Weaver. He had to find out, he had to know the Truth... That's why he decided not to inform Glimmer, at least for now, but to observe the girl, waiting to learn something specific.

So he went with Tirin and started telling her about Brightmoon and Etheri in general, showing her around the capital. The girl listened to him with interest and even relaxed a little. He tried not to tell her too much about the country's secrets, which wasn't difficult because he knew enough stories himself that he could go on for hours, or even days. He didn't even notice when he started talking about Mystacor.

„So you studied in a real ancient school of magic like in the old stories, with owls and brooms, not one of these modern schools full of computers and Holographic glyphs?” the girl asked, revealing again that she was from outside the empire. Mystacor was the only magical school in this part of the galaxy, as magic

had been forgotten here, but the sorceress Saihe , who accompanied Shadow Weaver, showed that sorcery was widely practiced elsewhere.

„Well, we don't have brooms and owls here, and we'll probably soon be using computers and other things to learn magic. My sister will take care of it.„ he smiled.

„Your sister teaches at school?” the girl asked curiously, and he mentally scolded himself for his talkativeness. He was no better at keeping secrets than this girl.

„Yes, she's a teacher... I think I'm a little hungry... do you have a place here?” when she shook her head in response, he smiled and took her to the inn he liked.

He was glad that no one here called him king, or worse, king consort. The locals were sensitive enough to know that this would reopen old wounds. He bowed to the host and his partner, then sat down at the table. He resisted the temptation to order wine and asked for lemonade and spicy vegetable cream. He asked Tirin if she wanted anything, but she only asked for hot water. She dissolved some gray-brown powder in it and carefully took off the mask and took a few breaths as if to test it, then she smiled and drank it all slowly, as if she was afraid of choking, and when she finished and saw him watching her, she explained.

„My digestive system does not function properly and my jaws are not as strong as in healthy people, so I have to drink special supplements. It doesn't bother me because I have no sense of smell or taste.” her voice did not come from her mouth, but from a small device near her larynx, she almost did not move her mouth. She smiled sadly, she was so young and delicate, younger than his daughter, about Frost=ay's age , although the ice princess looked much healthier. Her lips were pinkish-brown and her teeth were bluish.

„What happened to you?” he asked in a frightened voice, and Tirin sighed and coughed, then with a little fear she put on her mask and told her story. Most of it was made up, but Jadehell's stay on this planet felt real. It was that place where Angela was imprisoned? Was her body as twisted as this girl's? Did the Azlanti Azlantii send their children to this cursed place? What kind of bastards send their own children there? Barely holding back the urge to hug her, he offered to rent her a room, but she shook her head and paid for the week in advance herself. She used coins of unknown origin, but this was not strange, the Empire was incredibly vast and they had not yet contacted all the planets conquered by the Horde.

„So you studied at this Mystacor ... Are there any other schools here? – she asked, clearly curious.

„There used to be Arcanacor and Umbracor, but they were destroyed in ancient times during the Sorcerer Wars...

“You fought wars here? I thought this was a good place.”

He smiled sadly.

„Sometimes good people do bad things and bad people do good things.” he said, thinking about the cursed Sorceress.

Bina found hiding in Brightmoon surprisingly easy. Most of the Lord Admiral's officers sat in the palace, and those who left, like Pahtra and the Skittermander Chorus, paid her no attention. Only Lady Ka or someone who knew her could be interested in her. She found out that she was here when she overheard several servants complaining about the Lord Admiral's "Left Hand." Luckily her fucked up sister avoided public appearances, after all she was a crazy murderess and not someone who liked the company of others, although she was clearly a member of his entourage. Only someone like Felix Antares could have felt that Ka could be entrusted with a responsible position... She had previously heard

rumors that the former "High Queen" was alive, but she had not told her children about them. Eti in particular had special reasons to hate the crazy murderess, so the news that she was alive could upset her, and the girl already had enough problems of her own. In fact, even Bina couldn't believe the news. She witnessed Igzar killing that bitch , but in the galaxy anything was possible. She saw with her own eyes how this She-Ra revived a kid. What was strange about her sister coming back from the dead?

However, she couldn't roam completely freely, if anyone recognized her, she would be in big trouble, but here her training came to the rescue. She always had a dressing up kit with her. She could change the length and color of her hair thanks to the hairstyle modulator. Holographic overlays and morphic makeup allowed her to change her facial features. The voice could remain the same as it was. This was one of the things that made Jantar's daughters different . Her voice was melodic and sexy, while Lady. Ka's was raspy and menacing. Well, it felt like old times, before she became a mother to her kids.

Taking care of her children made her sleepless. She was afraid of what might happen to them, and life had taught her that you should always expect the worst. But if that witch did anything to them... It would be better for her if she had never been born. She didn't like violence, but Jantar had crammed enough knowledge into her head that she could make someone plead for Mercy, and she had learned this and that from Igzar's subordinates , so when the Shadow Weaver fell into her hands and her children would not be safe and sound , then he promises that he will teach her what Pain is.

Unfortunately, she didn't find out much about where her kids might have been hiding. While drinking with the quite nice palace guards, she learned that there had been a break-in in the castle. No one knew exactly who had done it, but considering that the Grand Marshal seemed shaken afterwards and Queen Glimmer was running around the castle with a black eye, then they must have been her kids. Only they could create so much Chaos and Confusion for absolutely no reason. However, this was far from

enough, she had to be close to the center of events, but not too close... Because she might come across Lady Ka, and their meeting would not end with a polite conversation.

She intended to employ herself in the entourage of one of the less important princesses, or one of the guests from other planets. So many of them came that the city was bursting at the seams. She spent the night with the innkeeper and his partner. She hadn't been with guys for a long time, but sex didn't bring the expected relaxation. She asked many people about employment opportunities, but received no confirmed news, and there was only one day left. She had to quickly find someone who would let her get closer to the manor.

So she went downstairs and ordered a tea with milk. She started looking at the inn's patrons and then she noticed a man who looked like an elderly wizard and a strange girl in a suit that was completely out of place on this planet, definitely too advanced for the local tech level. An unusual view and in some regions of the galaxy it would evoke unambiguous associations, but not in this context. The man was strangely tense, and the girl... She had a good ear for accents and recognized distinct Azlantean features in her pronunciation. It was interesting and disturbing. They had fought the Antis on Saltmarsh, and she guessed that the Empire had plans for the place. The Lord Admiral may be a bastard, but his resources were limited and he couldn't conquer this planet. But this band of bastards led the most powerful, and many would say the most evil, empire in the galaxy, hated by all but the human species . They were more powerful than the Horde and just as evil, though in a much less obvious way. Etheria was an incredibly ethnically diverse place, even by Absalom's standards, but humans made up a significant percentage of the planet's inhabitants, and the Star Empire might feel obliged to restore the most perfect species in the Galaxy to its rightful position of rulers of lesser species. The girl looked harmless, but her accent was typical of the Azlantean aristocracy, in whose veins flowed the pure blood of descendants of an ancient empire supposedly derived from the Lost Golarion. Some people claimed that the leaders of the Empire were truly superhuman, more efficient and

intelligent than others, although this girl definitely did not confirm this statement. She seemed scared and so fragile that if you took her out of that suit, she would fall to pieces. However, appearances can be deceiving. She knew something about it, she knew the truth about Felix Antares after all ...

She waited until the man left the table and followed him. She expected him to go to the toilet, but he stood at the back of the inn, lost in thought. As soon as she approached him, he quickly turned around, summoning a spell, and growled.

„Who are you and why are you following me!”

She raised her hands to show that she had no hostile intentions and said.

„I didn't mean to do anything bad to you. I came to warn you. This girl is not who she seems!”

„So who is she?” he asked, smiling menacingly.

„She is an Azlanti ... That is, a member of a powerful empire proclaiming the supremacy of the human species using its war machine.” she quickly explained as best as she could one of the most alien aspects of the galaxy to the inhabitants of Etheria.

„So she was telling the truth.” he said and lowered his hands, canceling the spell.

“Who was telling the truth?” she asked discomfited.

„A certain wicked woman who decided to tell the truth this once.” he said, looking depressed.

Something about his attitude made her suspicious, so she asked.

„She? You mean a tall woman with pointy ears and a gloomy disposition... She hides terrible scars.”

„ So you know Shadow Weaver? – asked the surprised wizard.

„”Do I know her? I brought her here and then entrusted her with the care of my children.” she explained, smiling sadly. He looked at her in disbelief and asked

„What you did?” she could hear the horror in his voice. She buried her face in her hands and groaned.

„I know this doesn't reflect very well on me, but in my defense, she was really nice during this journey.”

The man smiled sadly and said.

„When it suited her, she perfectly pretended to be nice and noble.”

Bina nodded and asked anxiously.

„And my kids? Have you met them? Are they okay?”

Understanding appeared on the man's face.

”Ah, Eti and her friends... It seemed to me that she didn't do anything to them. Actually, it seemed to me that they didn't respect Shadow Weaver very much... But that was a few days ago, I don't know what happened to them after that. – Hope suddenly sparkled in his eyes. “That means you met my wife… Moonshadow… Captain Moonshadow.” the wizard had so much despair in his voice that her heart ached.

„Yeah, I saw her... We were traveling together and she seemed fine, but then she attacked Adora and killed that kid.” she saw that the wizard's face was pierced by a spasm of pain, so she added. “But that's what Lady Cala was talking about, and she's sticking with Shadow Weaver. “ she explained and suddenly realized something. „ Wait, since she is the queen and you are her husband... „ she fell on her knees in front of him, but he grabbed her and lifted her „Don't kneel, I'm just the King Consort and an ex at that. But it's good to hear from someone else that my wife is alive... „ he smiled gratefully and added. “What will we do with this Azlanti?”

She smiled and said.

„I have a plan, could you get me a job as an guide?”

They did not land at the airport, but in the middle of nowhere near the capital. It was not easy to find a place suitable for a ship as large as theirs, but fortunately no one on the planet was supervising the flight of ships that entered the atmosphere, or so they thought, so they could search for a landing pad as long as possible. they just wanted to. Lonnie looked at the monitor curiously, it wasn't her first time flying in the air, like for Rogelio and Kyle, but Imp was scared, which was ironic because of his wings . Well, she didn't feel sorry for him in the slightest. She never liked Hordak's failed creation, he was nosy and cunning, and after she found out how her former master treated their daughter, her dislike grew even stronger. Nightgale looked thoughtful, even distressed, though she wouldn't say why. She didn't pressure her. Devils and demons witnessed that everyone had the right to secrets. Kyle, on the other hand, looked guilty and scared, but there was a steely determination she had never expected from him. However, she guessed what was the reason for his unusual behavior. Eti sat on the sidelines and stared thoughtfully into space. Rosie tried to talk to her, but the cat-like girl only answered in half words. She sighed, it had to happen eventually and walked over to her.

„So you already know... you probably hate me now...”

Eti shook her head

„I don't hate you, Shadow Weaver. You didn't do anything to me. You were even good to me and even saved my life. You didn't do it completely selflessly. You're looking for redemption, but you won't find it with me. You can only get it from the one you hurt, but she won't give it to you because she hates you more than anything in the world”

She felt an unbearable pain in her heart, because the girl was right. There was no forgiveness for her.

After landing, Szrama handed out costumes to her friends. Itel and Rosie had their dresses, they didn't even have to hide their weapons. Alatar and Lilka disguised themselves as Ashrak sellers, they even had a self-propelled thermos, which Bina bought... She missed her and was even a little worried, but these emotions were obscured by a storm of cold flame raging in her heart... The Blonde Boy was dressed in a black silk vest with gold decorations. He looked a bit like a dandy, although he acted as clumsy as before. Gadzio wore clothes similar to those worn by other Vesks in the Scarlet Husk . Scar also wore a desert outfit that obscured her face. This sorceress, Red, Scar's right hand, wore a blue cloak decorated with glittering stars. Shadow Weaver looked at it as if it reminded her of something, but then thought better of it. The dark sorceress herself simply changed her eye and hair color. She was supposed to stay in the shadows anyway and not attract anyone's attention. Ireanis dyed her hair pink and wore a very sexy dress in the style of those fashionable on Absalom . Wrongdak removed the paint and donned the engineering outfit popular among clone technicians throughout Etheria . And she... Well, everyone expected her to hide and not show herself to anyone... But she had other plans.

They split into three groups. The girls were supposed to wear their dresses only near the city so that they would not get damaged. She got ahead, no one noticed. She was a scout, after all. In the city, she slipped between the crowds of guests unnoticed without any major difficulties... After all, she was absolutely perfect, amazing and Unique. She finally reached her destination. The tailor's shop was closed due to the holiday, so she got in through the window without any problems.

„Me about my outfit.” she said, suddenly revealing her presence. The seamstresses jumped in fear, probably close to having a heart attack.

„Ah, it's you. This is how it is ready... As per your order.” said the older one. She handed the clothes to Eti, who went to the changing room and tried on her new clothes, then put on her coat. It was perfect.

„You'd also need a mask, because a masquerade ball was organized at the last minute.” said the elderly seamstress and pointed to the wall, where there were lots of different masks. She saw one that she particularly liked.

„I'll take this one.” she said, pointing to a mask depicting a wolf. Yes, it's finally time to remember her heritage.

Oaths

Chapter Notes

> Well, this is the next chapter. Melog is He/Him because that's how it was in the Polish version. Please leave your comments and opinions here. They will give me great pleasure.

=

„Okay, is it perfect now? What do you think?” she asked Melog, who grunted with satisfaction, although she doubted whether he cared what outfit she wore... Maybe not... It was hard to say what was hidden her companion's heart. Despite their bond, she actually knew very little about the shape-shifting alien. Even his form wasn't his true form after all, maybe he didn't even have one. It was weird, even Double Trouble had their true form. On a sudden impulse, she approached her unusual friend and touched his cheek.

„Today is our big day, my dear. You will become a member of our big, strange and patchworked family.” she said tenderly with closed eyes, but Melog sent her a wave of anxiety. She looked at him confused.

„What is it about? You're not afraid of being left out, are you? Is it about this Lord Admiral’s wolf... My father’s Wolf” Her companion flinched when she mentioned the Lord Admiral, so she decided to focus on that topic. “I know, he's a very intimidating individual and that wolf of his looks like he wants to eat everyone who happens to be in the room with him, but you'll get used to it.” she said, stroking him. Melog sent her a vision. Lady Cala Grayskull appeared first, smiling as always. The blue in her eyes was unnaturally intense... She herself looked ominous, as if she were radiating light, but it was a different light than the one radiating from Adora when she was She-Ra. It was cold, it gave no warmth, and it exposed the soul to make it easier to see through it so that

it could be judged. She shivered because it brought back terrible memories that she didn't want to recall.

„She's not like him.” she whispered to her companion to calm both him and herself. She didn't like this girl, she told Adora that from the very beginning. Her scent was unnatural, her smile that never left her face hid something dark inside, and her eyes were cold as ice... Adora trusted her a little more, apparently she saw a bit of herself in her, or maybe rather someone she wanted... No, one who she believe she should be. Even after Lady Cala had upset her during that training session, her fiancée couldn't stay mad at her for long. Yes, they need to keep an eye on Lady Grayskull…

But then Melog sent her another vision. She saw her father in a long, elegant coat standing in the middle of the battlefield. There were no enemy soldiers around, and there was an ominous, oppressive calm. The banners of the Fearless Armada fluttered over the battlefield, and those of the enemy lay shattered. Dusk was falling and the shadows began to lengthen, covering everything around them. It also brought back bad memories, years of suffering when she lived under Shadow Weaver's supervision. Her father stood against the blood-red setting sun. Darkness wrapped around him like a robe…. Shadows seemed to flow from him, consuming everything around him. In the end, all that remained was a d ark silhouette with the world burning behind it. Two eyes, one intensely blue and the other red like the sun behind him, glowed as if they were staring at her. She pushed Melog away angrily.

„He's not like that. He's not like Shadow Weaver…. He can't be like that!” she called to her companion, who was staring at her with fear and resentment. She sighed and hugged the shapeshifting alien.

„I'm sorry Melog, I shouldn't have done that. I just... I really wish he could be the father I deserve. I never thought about having parents... a family bigger than the one I would create with Adora . But now I finally have someone I can see myself in. Thanks to which I will understand who I am. That's why I don't want him to

turn out to be someone other than he seems. I know he has a darkness in him, but I have it too . I can't reject him for that reason... I want him to be my father...„ she said, tears flowing down her cheek. She just realized that this was the case. She really wanted the Lord Admiral to become a part of her life. She wasn't sure when it happened. Was it when he asked her to join him during the war with Horde Prime's Heirs , or maybe earlier... During that dinner... Or maybe even breakfast, when she learned about her past? It didn't matter what happened, what mattered was what resulted from it. With the arrival of the Lord Admiral, not only did the universe they knew expand, but her personal universe also grew to unimaginable proportions. She was no longer an orphan with no past, a damn cardboard kitten. She had her inheritance, even if she had to fight for it. She was who she always wanted to be. Maybe deep down she always knew who she was? That's why she strived for greatness, for power, even at the cost of harming everyone who cared about her and self-destruction? This knowledge, this awareness overwhelmed her, but at the same time it gave her an energy she had never experienced before. She felt like the whole universe was open to her... But there was also the matter of her sister. The girl claimed that their father was a liar. That she couldn't trust him. Maybe it was true… But she didn't even want to consider it. Not without credible evidence. This must have been Shadow Weaver's plot. This woman wanted to destroy her life again. She took revenge on her for daring to defy her. She wanted to punish her for taking away her power... She once made her hate Adora ... and herself. Now she wanted to repeat the same thing with her father. He won't let her do that... But first she has to save her sister, before the Dark Sorceress hurts that girl as much as she did to her. It was a priority. It wasn't going to be easy... Maybe she needed help from someone tougher... Stronger and Cunning than any of the princesses, Glimmer or even She-Ra.

„You know, my dear, I think I've made a decision!” she said smiling, but Melog sent her a wave of concern.

„You know, you really look great, and I'm not just saying that because I'm your steed. I know perfectly well how to be beautiful!” Swiftwind said enthusiastically. She laughed, amused that her own horse was helping her with the final wedding preparations. Yesterday she decided that Swiftwind would lead her to the wedding. He was the closest thing she had to family, though considering she was actually the one who gave him his intelligence, she was sort of his parent or master... It was quite a strange thought. However, on Etheria it often happened that children or wards led their parents or masters into marriage, so everything was probably fine.

„I'll be getting married as Adora, so your mane and wings will dwarf me anyway.” she said and laughed. She decided to say the words of the vow in her natural form, because Catra preferred to marry her and not She-Ra. After all, they had known each other long before she found the sword of protection.

„And who will Melog and I actually be? Will he become my brother, brother-in-law or maybe cousin?”Aricorn asked. He had long been jealous of the strength of the bond the shapeshifting alien had formed with her fiancée.

„I have no idea, but you both will definitely be our best friends!” she said and kissed him on the nose. Then tears appeared in Swiftwind's eyes.

„My little Adora is getting married... I'm so happy„ he said and burst into tears. She hugged him tightly with all her strength .

„Oh, don't worry, my love! We will always be together!” She said as she felt tears streaming down her face. In fact, they knew little about the previous She-Ras and the bond they had with their mounts. They didn't even know if Mara really had that dragon mount. At least dragons really existed. And Dragonkini . Suddenly she remembered something

„Swiftwind … You said you met another Dragonkin earlier, right? The one whose name was the same as Tarek's nephew?” she

asked carefully, and her mount nodded enthusiastically.

„Yes! His name was Alatar! What do you mean?” he asked, and she thought for a moment about what she should answer. She remembered that Catra's sister's group of burglars included a silver-scaled Dragonkin.

„Was anyone accompanying this Dragonkin?” she asked carefully so that he wouldn't feel her anxiety.

„Yes. There was this deaf girl with talking gloves. She was quite nice. Apart from her, there were also: A red-haired girl who hugged me and called me horse, it was strange. The tattooed Saihe, who was interested in our history and the sword, and the girl in the cloak with a mask and goggles. First she said that I was widely known throughout the Galaxy, and then she asked if if I were eaten, would I count as white meat or red meat…. It was quite terrifying. They wanted a permit from me to sell some tea and I gave it to them. Adora, has something happened?” he looked at her strangely, she probably looked worried.

„Was there anyone else? Someone they were afraid of? Or maybe some strange shadows…„ she tried to hide her anxiety, but she was never good at controlling her emotions.

„They probably had a guardian, but they certainly weren't afraid of him. It was me who was afraid of them... And now I'm a little afraid for you, because you made such a face that... „ Swiftwind's voice was really scared now. She felt confused herself now . The girl in the cloak was Catra's sister. She was sure of that. Even her sense of humor was a bit like Catra's, only more... gruesome... But if Shadow Weaver was with them, where was she hiding? She always liked to control everything from behind... from the shadows... They probably couldn't tell anyone about her existence under pain of terrible punishment... There was just something that didn't feel right here. True to Swiftwind's words, they were rather naughty and self-confident, not something Shadow Weaver would tolerate in others. And why did this girl ask about the sword... Maybe she didn't tell them the truth about what

happened here. Well, that would be exactly like her. She had always considered secrets and mysteries as much of a weapon as sorcery and tanks. But something still didn't feel right to her.

„It's very complicated, but I can't tell you anything yet, but I promise you will find out everything soon. For now, I have an important task for you...”

„I don't know, but I'd rather get married in armor.” she said, looking suspiciously at her reflection in the mirror. “Especially since in a few months I won't be able to wear it anyway, because you know!” she turned to High Minister Shu , who stood nervously clutching her hat with flowers.

„This is supposed to be a celebration of peace, not a message that we are preparing for another war. And so the Lord Admiral and his entourage will wear military uniforms, we don't have to.” said the otter woman, trying to sound as dignified as always, but the arrival of the Starfleet soldiers made her very nervous, and not only because she had more work to do. She didn't agree with her decision, which wasn't surprising at all. She wasn't sure if she agreed with herself. But it was too late to change my mind.

„Maybe you're right, but I still want to be more... fighty...„ she said, not sure if she used the right words. Everything that's happened lately has been so overwhelming.

Suddenly, a guard peeked in, saying that Storm Heart, the Guardian of the Storm from the Islands of Sorrow wanted to meet her. She sighed heavily and let him in. She just hoped it would be less annoying than Midnight Mask.

The woman who entered her chamber was much taller than Black Blade. She was dressed in beautiful armor made as if from the chitin of giant insects, and on her back she had a glaive. Her face was covered with a veil like all her compatriots, but the part that

was visible indicated that she was related to Midnight Mask , and therefore...

„Are you the other Shadow Weaver sister, the one Catra met in the Kingdom of Snow? Were you the one who supported the chancellor when he wanted to overthrow Frosta?„ she said firmly, and the woman nodded and said.

„I only did what was in the interest of my country. As a responsible queen, you should understand this... The girl was very lucky anyway. In my country, she would be executed for weakness unworthy of a ruler.” she said in a serious, but also slightly sad tone. She pursed her lips and drawled, barely stopping herself from bursting into Fury.

„Listen to me! We in Etheria do not follow such rules. Power does not belong to the one who is strongest, but to the one who cares for the weaker. Showing weakness is not something we should avoid, because our loved ones will support us .„ She looked at Storm Heart and she replied.

„If this is how you imagine exercising power, it is no wonder that you have a problem with rebellion, and your own subjects do not want be ruled by you...

Now she teleported in front of the woman and shouted at her

„Who are you to threaten me in my own palace!” she summoned the projectiles to her hand, but the Guardian of the Storm shook her head.

„I'm just warning you. I would be sorry if you were exiled. You are the heroes of Etheria , the ones who ended the tyranny of Horde Prime. His rule also cost us a lot. For my Mother and sister, you are only strangers whose lives are worth as much as raindrops, but I see in you Honor, which even the faithful sometimes lack.” she said in the gentle but strong voice of someone who had commanded in both war and peace.

„Why did you come here! Tell me and don't spoil the most important day of my life!” she ordered , and Storm Heart knelt down on one knee in front of her and said.

„There may be many differences between us. In the old days, we sometimes fought wars, and still most of my compatriots consider you less worthy than shadow spiders, because they are born with an understanding of what is beauty in order... But I know that we must try to understand you and start accepting you, because our universe became much bigger. If we don't open our doors, the universe will break them down. Therefore, I would like to ask you to allow me and my sister to participate in the Victory Day celebrations and wedding ceremonies. –

She stared at the woman from the Sorrow Islands for a moment, wondering if she should agree to her request. If she was anything like Shadow Weaver, she was definitely up to something... But then again, she couldn't refuse the outstretched hand. So she sighed and said.

„All inhabitants of Etheria are invited, including you. But you better not betray our trust. Don't think we are naive and powerless... Horde Prime thought so too.”

Storm Heart stood up and bowed to her once more and headed to leave, but she stopped her by asking a question.

„Your mother... What is she like?”

The Stormkeeper stopped and answered her slowly and thoughtfully.

„She is a strong, strict and demanding woman... Like every ruler.”

She smiled at Storm Heart.

"I think I know something about it..." she said, but the Storm Guardian shook her head.

„NO. You do not know anything. You'd have to get to know her to understand, and I don't want that for you. „ and she left, leaving the queen in thought.

She felt better now. She was no longer sad and depressed all the time, only sometimes, mostly in the evenings. She had to admit that she liked living with Spinnerella and Netossa . The women were caring and helped her get out of her despair, at least partially. The princesses of the United Kingdoms did not care so much about ceremonial and court etiquette. In fact, they had almost no court at all. They placed the management of the state mainly on the shoulders of officials, and they themselves dealt mainly with running the court and making official appearances, sometimes only conferring with the High Minister for an hour or two. It was something completely different than what she was used to, but she liked it. Everyone here was more open and direct than in the Kingdom of Snow, and she didn't feel like she had to constantly try to meet someone else's expectations. But it wasn't her home...

She willingly helped with taking care of the baby and cleaning and cooking, although she did not know much about the latter, although her cream soup with seafood was very tasty to Netossa and Greypaw . She wanted to feel needed. That's why she was very happy when Glimmer upheld her decision to be the main bodyguard at the wedding...

However, when they got there, it turned out that there was much more work ahead of her than she expected. Glimmer had invited anyone who would like to come, and probably half of the planet's inhabitants… and many from nearby planets… In short, there were more people in Brightmoon than she had ever seen… And she liked it! Other news, however, was much more surprising.

Catra's Dad appeared on Etheria . It was amazing! He came from outside the Empire, from the distant corners of the Galaxy, specially for his Daughter's wedding. It was so great and

awesome! No one ever thought something so unusual could happen, although no one actually thought Catra was from outside Etheria . It was very strange, but then it explained why she wasn't like Greypaw. Netossa didn't seem surprised though, at least not as surprised as the others, maybe she had heard something from Catra? Back when she was trapped underground with Nightgale...? She wasn't sure, maybe she should ask the ruler of Armoria , but she didn't want to think back to those moments. It hurt her too much to see her moment of triumph turn into defeat.

They went with Netossa and Shogi to Glimmer while Spinerella stayed with the children. Her wife was to join them once she had discussed everything with the Queen. However, on the way, they heard Adora's scream.

„Frosta! Great to see you! I have an important task for you!”

She turned in the direction the voice came from and saw her friend and Swiftwind ! She ran to her and hugged him tightly.

„I'm also so glad to see you!” she exclaimed happily and added. “What a task! Please tell me!!” she said, almost forgetting about Nettos .

„Oh, it's something simple, but very important. I want you and Swiftwind to look for someone after the ceremony.

She was about to shout that she agreed when she remembered her companion, but the ruler of Armoria nodded, smiling warmly. So it's time for a secret mission for Glimmer. She will show everyone that she can be counted on.

The Lord Protector of Antares , Admiral of the Fearless Armada and Supreme Commander of the Research and Exploration Fleet, donned the finest attire in his possession for the occasion. It was decorated with gold threads made of material brought down from heaven, but the buttons were made of red steel mined in hell. The material was a mixture of lunar silk produced by some of the

Desnite orders of Castroval and wool from hair of Doom Moth from the Apostate. The leather pieces were made from Linnorm and Dragon skins. Everything wash infused with nanites, which not only cleaned it, but also repaired it, making it almost impossible to destroy. It was also strong enough to protect against being shot even with heavy weapons. It was a Treasure passed down through the line of the Lord Protectors of Tarak from time immemorial. Now it will become a legacy and a symbol of the power of the Protector Lords of Taurus and other planets that... would be liberated from the hands of the heirs of Horde Prime, which he will pass on to his daughter, and she to her descendants, until the end of time.

Everything was going great. All resistance on Taurus was crushed, and most of the former Rebels either swore allegiance to him or laid down their weapons. The authorities of the Pact Worlds and Veskarium, after receiving reports presenting his achievements in the most positive light possible, expressed their appreciation and promised to continue supporting his activities.

However, what was more important was that he was winning his Daughter's heart . It required a lot of patience and great delicacy on his part, but he was almost certain that he was close to winning her over to their common cause. Through the method of small steps, small concessions and moral compromises, he will make her the perfect successor to the ancient family bearing the surname Antares in recent centuries . He knew that he owed much of his success to this dark sorceress. It was through fear of her machinations that he was able to gain her trust. It was enough to show a little understanding and support, and she stopped seeing him as a threat and saw him as a valuable ally in the fight against the woman she hated with all her heart. As soon as he meets Shadow Weaver, he will have to repay her somehow... Of course, then he will kill her. No one can shed the blood of House Antares with impunity.

While he was thinking this way, there was a knock on the door of the room that the queen had lent him. He told his guards to let the guy in. It was his daughter and this strange feline creature

that made Resh stand up, but motioned for the Nightmare Hunter to lie down again and asked.

„Good evening my daughter. The ceremony is coming soon. This may be the most beautiful day of your life. Shouldn't you be preparing for it?” he said in a gentle, slightly amused voice. Catra smiled nervously and said

„I won't be more ready.„ her eyes were nervous, like someone who has just made a difficult decision and is afraid that she will change her mind. “I've decided. I'll go with you. I don't know when exactly I'll do it, I have some things to wrap up here, but I'll join you.” she added.

Perfect, he thought, but he recalled concern and anxiety.

“Have you talked to Adora about this? It would be bad if this issue divided you...„ He was honest. This relationship was more important in the long run than Catra's participation in their war, at least at this stage was not yet necessary. She-Ra was an extremely important ally, but more importantly, her genes would strengthen their bloodline. „This is not a decision you should make without careful consideration.„ he said, giving his voice a hint of guilt, but his daughter shook her head and said.

„I'll talk to her. I'm sure I can convince her. We're all fed up with this waiting. Glimmer will form an alliance today and will definitely agree to let us support you. That's why we do all this. To spread peace and magic to the galaxy... We have a fleet, just untrained, but if your officers would teach us how to fight... If we don't fight, the Horde Ultimate and the Heavenly Brothers will come to us sooner or later...”

You just gave me a great idea to solve a problem with Queen, he thought and placed a gentle hand on his daughter's shoulder. They both didn't like it when someone invaded their personal space, but at this moment, a little closeness was necessary.

„You will make whatever decision you see fit. I will support you no matter what you decide.” he said , trying to sound as fatherly as he could. The girl nodded and looked into his eyes.

„However, I have one request. Before I go with you... I have suspicions that my sister is on the planet... She's in the clutches of Shadow Weaver, who you knew as Miss Daisy... I don't know how she captured her, but I'm sure he's keeping her captive. I need your help to free her.” her voice was filled with fear and desperation… He had to calm her down now… A little. He looked at her seriously and said.

„I figured this out some time ago. You don't have to ask me for anything in this matter. I will use all available resources to free her... No one is allowed to harm the members of House Antares . I swear your sister will be free and Shadow Weaver will get the punishment she deserves...

“I really should thank this woman for everything she did for me.”

Lady Sorrowflame was glad she went to this library. Although she didn't come close to solving the mystery of this planet during these few days, the pleasure of conducting research in a traditional way was worth it. Apart from that, she came across some interesting clues that would surely lead her to the solution... She had to learn more about including Aaravos and its planet Xadia. Lance and George didn't know anything about it, though she didn't want to ask them directly so they wouldn't get suspicious. They were extremely kind and trusting, even by Etheria's standards . Unfortunately, she hadn't been able to find much about the Elven Warlock or the place he inhabited. However, she did not have time to search the entire library. For a moment she considered killing or transforming them, but she resisted the temptation. Good and truly dedicated librarians were too valuable to be foolishly wasted . Besides, they were the fathers of the royal consort, their disappearance would cause too much confusion.

And then they offered to give her a ride to Brightmoon . How could she hurt such polite people?

In Brightmoon , she learned that the Lord Admiral had convinced the Queen to bring her fleet here, although the locals were very confused. Her commander clearly wasted no time. She intended to meet him only after the Wedding Ceremony . Antares could be surprisingly sentimental about certain things when tradition was involved. Well, she understood him well, she was attached to her herself. After all, she was old when most ancient traditions were just born. The wedding was to take place under the open sky, in the light of these strange moons emanating power, in the presence of thousands of witnesses. It was a huge event of state importance, she had not participated in anything like it for decades, the last time was at the Lord Admiral's Grandmother's. His father never married his mistress, and Antares was never in a serious relationship. His family did not wear crowns, they had no need for such things to emphasize their power, so no coronation ever took place. It was simply that Parliament voluntarily, although of course not unanimously, gave them the title of Lord Protector. The Antares have always maintained the appearance of law and order.

Lance and George left her right afterward as they greeted their countless sons, including the Queen's future husband. Reflecting on the quality of social support on this planet, she took a seat in the section of the audience reserved for the Lord Admiral's subordinates. She sat down next to Mrs. Ka, who nodded her greetings.

„And how did it go for Antares?” she asked in a low voice.

„Surprisingly good, although we should get used to the fact that the boss knows perfectly well how to trick others. As for the information you are interested in, here is the second kitten, and therefore your dream artifact”

She looked at the Intelligence Officer and smiled.

„I'll find many more ancient treasures here, but this one was particularly valuable. Thank you for your message. “ she said, smiling at her friend and lover.

Soon the ceremony began. She was secular, much to the chagrin of Lady Sorrowflame. The local people weren't very religious, which was quite interesting. She herself had been a devoted priestess of Dahak for countless centuries and could not fathom such ignorance. Faith was important to her, even after her God died, and she respected true believers, even if she fed on them. In a way, even Horde Prime's clones were better in this respect, because their faith was sincere, although directed towards a false god.

The queen's aunt spoke first, apparently her name was Castaspella, although she didn't believe it was her real name, no one would have such a stupid name, it was probably just a nickname. She talked about peace, the power of friendship and love, and all that nonsense. At some point she started to fall asleep listening to this senseless chatter, but eventually it all ended and the bride and groom stepped forward, led by their loved ones. The Queen was led by her father, who seemed to be a wizard, and by her future husband, Lance and George. The Lord Admiral led his daughter away and Adora was led by some kind of winged unicorn, quite a strange and ridiculous sight, but she was starting to get used to the fact that strangeness was the norm here. Then the Queen and her fiancé approached the Mistress of Ceremonies and began to sing, taking turns, a song about a long-standing friendship that, despite the pain of loss and misunderstandings, survived and finally blossomed into love that culminated here. Boredom again. She hadn't loved anyone for so many centuries that she was beginning to doubt that love was anything more than the drug reaction of a hormone-addled Brain. Unfortunately, the music was far too loud for her to sleep, so she looked around in boredom, wondering what the locals looked like as choir of ghouls. Finally the commotion ended and Castaspella asked solemnly.

„Do you, Glimmer Moonbright , and you, Bow of the Forest Library, make an oath to each other in the moonlight, you will support and love each other no matter what the future holds for you.

„We swear!„ They shouted at the same time and Glimmer jumped on her husband and kissed him, hanging on his neck .

„Well, you're married... You're not listening to me anyway... You could have at least waited until I finished... „ said the mistress of ceremonies, and Lady Sorrowflame seriously wondered whether the bride and groom were about to start their wedding night despite the presence of thousands of people. However, they immediately took a seat at the table, hugging each other. Then the Lord Admiral's daughter and her fiancée stepped forward , and Catra's strange creature stood at her feet. Both girls began to sing a song about their love. It told the story of growing up in the Barracks under the watchful eye of the Lord of Shadows, being separated by war and hatred, anger and sadness burning in their hearts, the coming of an invader, a desperate rescue, reunification, a final battle and a declaration of love. This song was a bit more interesting because it concerned matters that directly concerned her. Then Castaspella said the formula again.

„Are you, Adora Rainbowpunch Happysmile, and you, Catra... „ at this point, the girl interrupted her.

„Catra Antares ... I would like to marry under this surname. – she said, and then everyone looked at her in surprise, even Antares , whose usually impassive face showed a smile, the first one she had ever seen on his face. Adora looked at her for a moment, then nodded. Castaspella then returned to reciting the words of the oath.

Are you Adora Rainbow Punch and you Catro Antares, do you make an oath to each other in the moonlight, you will support and love each other no matter what the future holds for you?

„I swear... „ Adora said, looking tenderly at her beloved.

„I swear... „ said her boss's daughter, love reflected in her multi”colored eyes.

„So you two are married...

„ The mistress of Ceremonies didn't finish because both girls started kissing. Castaspella sighed in resignation, and cheers echoed throughout Brightmoon . But she paid no attention to it anymore, for she sensed the evil approaching… Evil born from the Darkness from between the stars …

All the Stars dance on Etheria

Chapter Notes

> Here's the next chapter. I changed the name general to the correct one. I warmly invite you to comment

A few hours earlier, before the words of the oath were spoken in Brightmoon far away, in the Singing Jungle, in the deserted, desolate hills, in a place where so much blood had recently been shed, evil was awakening. Ancient and terrible, dating back to times older than the kingdom of Etheria, older than the Civilization of First Ones, and even older than the stars themselves! The spilled blood has power, just like death on the battlefield... This power did not dissolve into the Winds of Magic blowing across the universe, but fed the creature resting in the stone standing in the middle of the battlefield. It was fed but did not satisfy, only stimulated hunger, which turned into Anger. It wasn't the blood of those he was promised. He was to receive a SACRIFICE. He would consume not only their blood, but also their souls, to digest them for Eons... But it was taken from him! He was deprived of what was promised to him! Such betrayal cannot be accepted! Anger and Hunger caused them to reach through time and space to a place called Etheria. He found that it was much easier than it should have been, this place had returned to the Material Plane. He drew power from the blood of the victims of the battle and poured his essence into the statue. The stone began to crumble, revealing a shape far more monstrous than anything the artists who carved the statue could have imagined. He spread his webbed wings and let out a piercing howl that cracked the rocks, and then he soared into the air, flying towards Brightmoon. His victims would not escape him, and perhaps in the process he would devour countless numbers of beings... However, he knew that this would not satisfy him. Nothing can do that.

Rosie found Brightmoon even more beautiful than last time. She lived at Absalom Station, so the crowds didn't scare her. In fact, there was a surprising order. Much stricter than most of the festivals and holidays she had attended on the space station. However, there were no crowds of guards enforcing the law, the residents themselves knew how they should behave. They didn't litter, they didn't get too drunk to stand up, they didn't start fights, or at least she didn't see anything like that, although the night was still young, anything could happen. It was very fun. Many types of music were played here, from electronic to harps and drums. They had to drag Lilka away from the latter because she wanted to show the musicians real orc rhythms. Of course, she didn't hear what they were playing, but she was able to enjoy certain types of music sensing it’s rhythm. There was a lot of food sold here, not the unhealthy junk food usually served at this type of event, but fresh and healthy delicacies. Most of them did not contain meat, so Alatar had to search around before finding something for himself. Eti will definitely complain, she loved meat and hated sweets, and there were plenty of the latter here too. She especially liked the homemade gingerbread and tartlets . There were a lot of Piñatas here , and they had to drag Lilka away from them, because she wanted to open them with her ax, and that seemed to defeat the purpose. There were also many games and activities. Shooting and throwing at targets, Lilka was again disconsolate because she was not allowed to throw an axe. Alatar, however, had great aim and won for Lilka the rag scorpion, she chose it herself, surprising everyone. There were also people who painted their faces and bodies, because this time the girl did something unexpected, she showed them how to draw real orcish tribal markings, and according to what Itel said, they were really orcish, identical to those worn by Warog, the orc who helped save them there on Kesler when they were fleeing the Hive invasion. The red-haired girl had started to change since they arrived on this planet. She was no longer as loud and belligerent as if she wanted to show the whole world that she couldn't beat her. But it was the same for all of them. Was it the planet that had this effect on them, or was it because of the events of the last few days? She couldn't answer that. She also felt that she had changed. She

felt like she was finally where she was supposed to be. It wasn't that she had found home, but rather the place she had been looking for all her life... Was she looking for it? Suddenly she felt cold sweat break out on her. It was true! This is where she was supposed to be from the very beginning! But how! After all, no one knew what Etheria was. A few years ago, no one even realized this planet existed. Its inhabitants were trapped in another plane... It happened thousands of years ago, and she was only found a few years ago, and before that she had been adrift for hundreds of years... Or at least that's what she was told... What if it wasn't hundreds, but thousands of years. What if she ended up in this capsule back when Etheria was in the material world and the First Ones ruled the galaxy. Who was she then? Was she one of them, like Adora? Is that why she had this power? Did all First Ones have it? She guess not... From what Kyle said , Adora was a normal girl, at most extremely fit. It was thanks to the sword that she became so powerful, and meanwhile she... She could fight like no one else, jump high, and even almost fly... And she glowed, you couldn't forget about that. But it is not everything. She was capable of much more when threatened. But then she lost her memory... And she did terrible things... This had never happened to her before ... but had she really? She didn't remember her past. Where she came from, who she once was and even her real name. She was a blank slate… She was less than a shadow. She felt tears welling up in her eyes. She sat up, trying to stop crying. She felt so alone.

Then a live report from the Royal Wedding appeared on the big screen. Not knowing what else to do with herself, she started watching the ceremony. The queen was very pretty and even radiant. She was relieved to see that there was no trace of her punch on her pleasant face. Then, in the palace, during the break-in, she was afraid that she might have killed her, she didn't know what she would do then. Then, after Glimmer had kissed her husband very passionately, it was time for her friend's sister and her fiancée. They looked very beautiful. Catra was lead by her father. She knew he was a very bad man, but when he was Carrying of his daughter like that, she thought they looked like a

real family. But Catra was an orphan for almost the entire time, raised by the military and Miss Daisy, that mean, by the Shadow Weaver... If she can find her family, maybe they will be able to find their loved ones too. When the oath was spoken, the crowd began to cheer and applaud. She joined in the applause, feeling as if she was sharing the happiness with everyone present. And then the fun started in full swing. She felt loud music playing and the guests scattering to places where they could dance. For a moment she wanted to follow them herself, but she had no one to go with, and they had tasks and such. But she still looked longingly at the couples going out to play. Then suddenly she felt a gentle touch on the back of her neck. She felt a chill because she knew who it was. She turned and saw Eti. The cat girl was in her usual outfit, covering her face and eyes. They agreed that she would dress so as not to attract too many glances because of her resemblance to her sister.

“Hey Sparklepaw, will you come dancing with me?” said Eti. She felt her heart start beating faster. Would she dance with Eti? But their mission and all!

“But Eti... We have a task... “she said, but then the scout wagged her tail angrily and said.

“The mission can wait. We have more important things... We are more important.” the cat-like girl grabbed her hands and led her to one of the dance halls. She felt that the music they played there was calmer, and so was the dancing performed there. Everything was hidden there in the twilight. The dim light made the atmosphere in this place particularly atmospheric. She could smell the faint scent of chocolate and cherries here. As they entered, Eti stopped and picked up her coat and mask, then handed it to the cloakroom attendant, who was staring at her with bulging eyes. Underneath her normal outfit, she wore a brown-green tailcoat with numerous metal decorations depicting some flowers.

“These are Sinistie from Atrax, the first living plants I saw...” she said and turned to the cloakroom attendant. “If you don't have my

coat, I'll do something painfully to you.” She looked at him menacingly, and he swallowed loudly and shook his head.

“Is what we are doing wise?” she asked her friend.

“No” Eti said briefly and dragged her to the dance floor. She didn't resist, in fact she wanted it very much, but it was very unreasonable! After all, everyone will see what Eti looks like and start wondering why she looks so similar to the Grand Marshal, especially since everyone recently had a chance to take a closer look at her. This could ruin the mission and... she found she didn't care at all. She really wanted to be here with Eti. Dance with her and… do other things… Like kiss her….

When they stood on the dance floor, they started dancing. Eti was leding. She was surprisingly good, although Rosie herself did not have enough experience in this matter, and the dance did not seem difficult. The scout didn't take off her glove, obviously not wanting to show her mutilated hand. She took off her gloves herself, she doesn't need them to talk to the cat girl anyway. The other metal hand was surprisingly warm to the touch and slightly electric to the touch, or maybe that was what she imagined? She felt Eti's breathing and stared into her sad and beautiful cat eyes. She was all very beautiful. She had never felt like this before, her heart was beating fast, her blood was pulsing, she felt hot. Was she sick? Some Etherian flu or something? Or maybe she was poisoned by something? Although she was unable to swallow anything due to her nerves before the mission. No, it was something completely different. In that one wonderful moment she realized that she loved Eti. She had never loved anyone before, or at least she didn't remember it, but that didn't matter now. Nothing mattered when she could be close to Eti. The cat girl also blushed, albeit slightly, and purred. The cat girl's entire body was trembling, hers too. She looked into those wonderful two-colored eyes and, without thinking about any consequences, she grabbed Eti by the neck and kissed her. The cat girl was surprised at first , but then she kissed him back. In that one moment, Rosie was the happiest being on Etheria .

Itel felt bitter watching Rosie and Eti kiss. She didn't expect that the deaf girl would be the one to initiate the kiss first, she seemed so innocent. On the other hand, Eti, contrary to what one might think, was very shy and secretive. She simply hid her emotions behind the mask of a scary cat girl, an assassin from the movies or a disturbing freak with a gun. For a moment she thought that Rosie had seduced Eti, pretending to be an innocent girl. Just a few days ago she would have clung to that thought and the hope within it, but not now. She accepted the loss, although her heart still hurt, as if someone had stuck glass shards stuck in it with salt and sulfur. Will this torment ever end? True to Shadow Weaver's words, but was she a person who had ever loved anyone? From what everyone said, she had always been a mean and selfish person, could someone so mean give others any love?

First, she was looking for Eti to protect her for getting lost somewhere and thus jeopardizing the mission. She had to leave Alatar and Lilka alone, even though the red-haired girl was strangely aroused today. She knew it would spell trouble, but letting Eti go would guarantee it. And then she saw the wedding broadcast on the big screens. He was there. She had never seen it in person, but she had watched it many times in different videos. It was he, the one who betrayed the people of Tarak and bombed his own planet, murdering millions. He led his daughter like nothing had happened, like a good, loving parent. Have they really not seen what a monster they let under their roof? How could they be so joyful? Did their naivety and ignorance know no bounds? For her it was unthinkable. But... Antares was a skillful manipulator, and the locals may have won a war against a mad tyrant like Horde Prime, but they did not know of such evil as Lord Admiral Felix Antares .

As she watched the two girls kiss, she made a decision . To the Abyss with the plans of the General's companion and to Hell with the rescue of Captain Blazebringer, none of it mattered to her now. She realized that she had only ever wanted one thing. Revenge, and there was only one way to get it.

They danced their old dance together, which they learned in the Fright Zone. One day, Shadow Weaver decided to teach them a bit of culture. They didn't know how the Dark Sorceress had managed to convince Hordak to let her engage in such a ridiculous activity. They assumed that she simply hid it from him or convinced him that it was just martial arts training. It turned out that Horde Prime taught his clones how to dance and even sing songs praising him in a choir. In a way, it was a very dark truth. Of course, he and Catra always danced together, which annoyed Shadow Weaver, but she didn't give up and pushed them so hard that Kyle once danced with Scarlet for two hours, even though she broke her ankle. Scarlet… Supposedly she was now a Sorceress and Lonnie's right-hand woman. Did she find time to dance while participating in their Rebellion?

Then the music slowed down and they danced together, hugging each other. They felt warm and good, she felt so happy. Bow and Glimmer were also beaming with joy. Given that the Queen can't drink alcohol right now, she'll want to have some fun in another way. Bow's has a very busy wedding night ahead of him. Her too, but they could have started earlier. Thanks to Melog, they could easily sneak away to get some love. However, one thing prevented her from fully enjoying her happiness. When they said the oath, a fiery red woman approached her father -in-law and started telling him something , pointing to the horizon. The Lord Admiral looked distressed and looked in the direction the woman had been pointing. Then he called Lady Ka to him and gave her some instructions, and then his Left Better Hand went somewhere and came back after a long time. Everything seemed to be back to normal, but four new guards appeared in the dance hall.

"Hey, Adora! Do you even have to worry on a day like this!" Catra said, smiling cockily. She smiled in response and kissed her wife… And then the Alarm sounded…

Calamity was glad that this bestiality farce called a wedding was over. Although when that idiot Adora let the fucking horse lead her to the wedding, she almost burst out laughing. Maybe it would be worth taking this mutant gelding to the glue factory? Unfortunately, that was all she had fun with. Now she had to endure the babbling of that idiot Klementyna. Her damned chatter gave her a headache. She swore that one day she would hang her prepared tongue around her neck. Unless she broke their neck first, which she really wanted to do.

"I'm so glad we're here together. You saw this ceremony yourself. On Etheria, we have stopped thinking about gods for too long. Most don't even remember them anymore. Yet faith is very strong throughout the galaxy. Just talk to our new guests... Or to you. Thanks to you, true faith will return to Etheria." said General's Juliette daughter. There was something strange in her eyes, she was probably high on something.

"In fact, thanks to me you will know what true divinity is."she said, although she doubted that what he was going to show her was what the girl dreamed of. Well, Calamity was a dream come true for many, but not necessarily in the way they wanted it to be. Her adoptive parents found this out belatedly, as did Shadow Weaver.

"Do you know that you are very beautiful?" Klementine asked , gently touching her cheek. She looked at the girl with confusion.

"Of course I know... A lot of effort was put into making me look absolutely perfect." she explained to the girl, trying to hide the irritation in her voice. Does he really have to explain obvious things like to a small child? However, the girl became sad, but continued to stare at her in this strange way. It took her a moment to realize that Klementine was in love with her. This unnerved her a bit. She had never practiced the art of seduction and pretending to love. Shadow Weaver herself had bluntly told her that she had absolutely no knowledge of such matters, although as it later turned out, she was not entirely green in this matter, as evidenced by the broken heart of a certain Hellknight. But for now, Klementine expected something from her. She had to

do something, because the girl was still very useful. She reached for the simplest solution and leaned over her. The General's daughter kissed her. It was surprisingly pleasant, she expected a wave of irresistible disgust to wash over her, as if she had touched something disgusting with her mouth , but her body was to some extent human, it had its own needs. Maybe this girl can provide her with something other than just screaming in agony.

"You're very beautiful too." she said, not really lying. The girl had symmetrical facial features with typical elven beauty. Of course, she was ugly compared to her, but there was no point in comparing mortals with perfection incarnate. General Juliette scowled at them. She didn't dance because she wasn't officially in a relationship with Onyx Sky, and at the same time she didn't want to dance with someone else so as not to offend them. She and Klementine dance for fifteen minutes, but then she felt something, a great power approaching. This worried her. Power always meant trouble, especially like this. She felt connected to her in some way. They were related, which meant that this being came from the cold and dark void that stretched between the stars. She searched her memory, but couldn't remember anything Shadow Weaver had told her that would indicate the presence of a similar creature on Etheria, although she had her suspicions.

Without a word of explanation, she left Klementine and went outside. She looked at the moon-filled horizon, but nothing she didn't see him there, but the power was still getting closer.

"Can you feel it too?" she heard a strong female voice. She turned around and saw a woman with fiery red hair. It was Lady Sorrowflame. She had heard something about this creature and now she realized that it was all true, albeit greatly diminished. Lady Sorrowflame was not human, or even mortal. There were layers of power hidden within it. The first was repulsive, disliked by most of her kind. She was an undead, and one of the most powerful. She felt hunger and thirst for blood, so she was either a vampire or perhaps a ghoul, but there was something else there. Something much older and more primal. She was like destruction

itself walking on the earth. She was a dragon, and an extremely powerful one at that. Powerful beyond all imagination.

“Yes, I sense trouble coming... If the fight breaks out, I advise you to stay away from She- Ra. Her light doesn't work well on people like you... People like us...” She smiled at Lady Sorrowflame , and then there was a deafening boom of an alarm.

The ceremony was so beautiful! He felt love floating in the air, he could absorb it with every breath. Something like this was worth getting married for... Well, maybe that's a bit of an exaggeration, but if she were to get married, she would want it to be like this... Although though she wasn't a princess and would have to settle for something much more modest. She also had no relatives, and was only friends with princesses, and would he be willing to come to an ordinary girl's wedding, even if she was their friend? Catra's dad looked like a real warrior with that scary metal eye. He also had many soldiers that looked even compared to the Clones. I wonder if they would help her get her kingdom back... No, that's a terrible idea. Who normal would fight with their subjects?!

But now there was no time for such considerations or for fun, although it seemed to be very fun. Adora assigned her an extremely important task. She was supposed to find a certain seller of exotic Tea. She didn't say why they were so important, but Adora asked her to find them and notify the guards. She was accompanied by Swiftwind and Shogi in the form of a goat. She mounted her friend and made her way through the happy crowds. She could barely hear Swiftwind humming the song Catra and Adora sang at their wedding. They wandered like this for an hour until they finally reached Swiftwind he exclaimed .

“There are!” Aricorn pointed with his horn at a couple of people standing next to a cart from which they were selling some steaming drink. She sucked in a sharp breath. One of them was a red-haired girl with tattoos and a strange outfit with lots of name tags. A blue fox was flying around her. But the most unusual thing

was the third person. She had seen someone like that before in pictures in fairy tale books. It was a dragon! Quite small for a dragon, but still a dragon! She forgot about Adora's order and immediately drove to him. A red-haired girl ran past her with a loud cry of "Horsee!"

“You are a Dragon... A True Dragon!” She exclaimed with delight, and the Dragon sighed heavily.

“This is the thirty-sixth time today that I am explaining that I am not a dragon, but a Dragonkin. Dragons are much bigger and more... Dragon-like in every way... Would you like a drink?” He asked with a bit of impatience in his voice.

“Oh... It's a pity...” she said, not hiding her disappointment.

“You're invading my personal space, and by the way, don't call me a horsy!” Swiftwind said to the redhead who was hugging him tightly. She frowned, got off the Shogi and walked up to the girl, then put her hand on her shoulder and said in a sharp tone.

“Leave my friend, you stupid girl!”

The redhead turned to her abruptly.

“Who are you calling stupid? You Stupid!” she pulled out a huge ax from behind her back.

“You are dumbest! You don't even know that guests are not allowed to carry weapons to the party!” she asked sarcastically .

“It's not a weapon, just an element of orc culture that I can wear whenever I want. Who are you to forbid me from doing anything? - said the red-haired girl, shaking her ax menacingly.

“I'm a prin ... I'm Frosta and I'm a security guard here, so I can absolutely forbid you to do this!” she shouted at the girl. “and I have absolutely no idea what Orks means!” she added.

“Because you're a stupid idiot, Frosta! An orc is someone like Lady Huntara or me!” the redhead screamed in an angry voice. At this time, the dragon approached them and spoke in a conciliatory tone.

“Girls, maybe instead of calling each other insults, we should talk, because everything will escalate and we will all do something we will regret. -his voice was gentle and calm.

“Yes, I agree with Mr. Alatar . With a cup of tea, everything seems to be right.” Swiftwind started , but she didn't listen to him.

“You are stupid! Huntara is not an orc and you are nothing like her!” she screamed. She summoned ice gloves. How dare this girl call her ignorant! She was always the best at the box office. Maybe the only one, but also the best! The redhead's face turned red and her ax caught fire.

“How dare you insult the honor of a true orc warrior! You insulted not only me, but also my clan and all the orcs! I challenge you to a duel on the beaten track!” she screamed.

“All right! Here and now, when I punch your stupid face, don't cry because it hurts!” she lost patience. Nobody respected her! First the Horde Ultimate, then the Chancellor, and now this stupid girl. She was about to fence the battle area with an ice ring when someone shouted at them.

“Lilka! Alatar! Oh, it's so good to see you.”

She looked over and saw a burgundy-haired woman. She ran up to them and hugged them one by one, and then she started screaming.

“What were you thinking! Where were you! -Where are Eti and Itel! Listen, Miss Daisy is not who she seems! This is...” she didn't finish because the red-haired woman, whose name was probably Lilka, interrupted.

"Yes, we know her name is Shadow Weaver and she raised Eti's sister and now Lonnie and I are on a very secret mission, but we are not allowed to tell anyone about it."

Alatar looked resignedly at the sky, and she stared at them in bewilderment. *Shadow Weaver is here? But how!* she thought, but before she could ask a question, the Alarm sounded.

Past crimes and future threats

Chapter Notes

Here's the next chapter. Web and Net in polish are the same word. I invite you to comment and please share your opinions

At this point, he was glad he is a clone. Thanks to this, he did not attract as much attention to himself as he should have. And he really didn't want to draw anyone's attention to himself. He was, after all, Hordak, the ruler of the Etherian Horde, who had been trying to enslave them all for thirty years in the name of the mad Tyrant. He may have been given from the queen's a break from the self-inflicted punishment, but not from the hatred of the common people of Etheria, nor from the remorse of conscience.

He was fully aware that he deserved their hatred, and that he was almost certainly in no danger. The inhabitants of Etheria were not vengeful and respected their ruler's decisions, but this did not mean that they would forgive him. He didn't deserve to be forgiven. Not after what he did. Even his punishment wasn't enough. In fact, he was happy with his wife and The Child. He was away from all those who remembered him as a tyrant and invader, but he did not forget it. Every day he woke up remembering what he had done to the inhabitants of this planet and thinking how he could atone for his guilt. Perhaps now would be his chance to atone for his actions, but he wasn't sure how much he could trust Shadow Weaver. She was always manipulating him into doing the worst... But she was right when she said the Lord Admiral was dangerous. He saw his soldiers on the streets of Brightmoon, although many were in plain clothes, but others were armed. He knew how to assess the fitness of enemy soldiers, and they looked extremely dangerous. They were slightly less fit and less trained than his brothers, but they were still far better than any of the soldiers he had fought… almost all of them, he couldn't forget about those knights and the monsters

that accompanied them. Of course, he was quite young and had not participated in many battles. He suspected that Horde Prime had deliberately sent him to such a risky fight to die because he was a defect, although in a completely different sense than he had always thought. These weren't memories he wanted to go back to. For many years he denied them, but something must have remained, because when he saw Imp, he gave him a name referring to the name of small monsters similar to him that harassed their forces during the fights. He didn't remember it before, only the strange and painful therapy performed by Entrapta allowed him to remember everything, even the things he preferred not to remember. Maybe if she had failed, he wouldn't feel so much remorse now? But it happened well. He didn't deserve to forgot his Crimes.

Nobody stopped him. Neither Brightmoon's guards nor these new soldiers paid him any attention. He was just one of the many clones that traveled across Etheria . The inhabitants of the planet weren't completely used to the presence of his brothers, he supposed that many were still afraid of them, but apart from a few reluctant to the new queen of places like Dryl, no one stopped them. He doubted they would cause him any major problems, after all he had the queen's permission, but he had his mission.

Another thing was that he wasn't sure if he was wise to cooperate with his former right-hand man. If someone found out that he was going to meet his former right-hand man, he would be in big trouble.

At any moment he could report that the Dark Sorceress was hiding somewhere here and might be planning something. Perhaps this way he would even redeem some of his sins and gain the trust of the inhabitants of Etheria. But if what Shadow Weaver said was true... Even now, she hid part of the truth from him. For example, that the Lord Admiral is Catra's father. This changed everything. He had no idea where Shadow Weaver got Catra from , from what Entrapta said, Catra herself didn't know. Of course, both the Dark Sorceress and her former ward could be lying, it wouldn't be the first time they had tried to manipulate one of

them. He especially found it hard to believe that Shadow Weaver had no idea about Catra's origins. He would never suspect her of such incompetence... This could all be another conspiracy of hers... But would it make sense? What would she gain by warning him about the Lord Admiral's true nature without telling him that he was Catra's father? He had no idea what she was up to, but he was going to keep an eye out. He won't let himself be deceived again. Never again!

But he had to admit, there was some truth in what Shadow Weaver was saying. The Lord Admiral's soldiers were extremely competent, and if more of them arrived, they could pose a real threat... Much greater than the Horde he had created. But apparently the queen was not concerned about the presence of a foreign army in her lands, although her subjects did not seem to be so open and looked at newcomers from outside the Empire with fear. Could they really be so ridiculously naive as to bring a foreign military here AGAIN? Or was Catra the one who convinced the Queen to work with her father? Maybe she planned with him to overthrow her so”called friends and rule Etheria like she always planned? You could expect the worst from this girl.

to Brightmoon in one of the Horde skimmers that he had designed. Entrapta improved it and now it was much more comfortable to drive. If only they weren't going to Brightmoon ... Although was there one place on Etheria he wanted to go? The city looked strangely colorful and chaotic, although he had to admit it was quite nice. He attempted to take the capital of Etheria for over thirty years , but was here only once, on trial after defeating Horde Prime. The process wasn't too long anyway. He pleaded guilty and then proposed punishment, and everyone agreed, although he supposed he owed a lot to Entrapta, who tirelessly convinced the princesses to give him a chance. However, he never had the opportunity to look at the capital. He and his wife and Child stopped on the outskirts of the city and separated there. His wife was to be present at the ceremony, while he was supposed to watch everything on TV screens. He convinced his wife that it was better for him not to be too close to Catra, which wasn't actually a lie, even though the relationship with his former

Second-in-Command was still strained. He felt bad not telling the whole truth to Entrapta, but he had to do it anyway... Even if he was ashamed of it. Not only because this way he had a chance to find redemption. He did it for his family.

He wasn't sure how well Shadow Weaver knew Brightmoon, but she probably could have picked a better place to meet them than the Brightmoon Cemetery ... It mean, in a way, it was a very good place to secretly plot. During this holiday, no one was going to visit the cemetery and there was absolutely no one here. It was quiet here... There was almost no sound of celebration, the festival lights were barely visible. Such things never amused him, so he was glad for the peace here... But it was a cemetery. Cemeteries bothered him. Horde Prime never cared about the lives of his little brothers and didn't bother to bury them. The corpses were recycled and turned into simple proteins useful in creating more clones. He destroyed cemeteries and tombs with the same fury as temples, often desecrating them with fury, and forbade his subjects to honor their dead. Not only because he was jealous of the respect they held for their ancestors, but he did not accept the idea that his subjects could escape him into the afterlife, that there would be some reward for them there, even though they opposed him. For him, the burial sites were disturbing for something else. They reminded him of all those who died because of him. Many of those buried here died during the war he caused. He felt like they were all accusing him. They ask what they had to die for. However, the idea that there is something after death somehow seemed tempting to him. Maybe countless numbers of his fallen brothers found happiness in a better place far from their mad creator, while Prime himself suffered eternal torment in some hell... If he suffered a similar fate to, he could accept it.

Brightmoin Cemetery looked like a park. There were trees and flower bushes everywhere. There were even a few fountains. Among the trees were many statues representing or commemorating the dead. The inhabitants of this kingdom scattered ashes in the ground to connect with the planet. From what he heard from his wife, the inhabitants of Brightmoon, unlike

the citizens of Eridani and some of the inhabitants of Icarus, did not have a unified vision of life after death, nor were they afraid of the return of their dead. His wife was fascinated by the idea of the afterlife and took it absolutely seriously, although she treated it in a very scientific way. She even considered building a portal to get there, but she didn't share the idea with anyone. He only found out about it because she was talking in her sleep. This plan was probably somehow related to what happened to her parents, but she didn't tell him much about it either.

In the center of the cemetery was a statue of Queen Angela . Her death also weighed heavily on his conscience. However, he shared this sin with Catra. If she hadn't deceived him, if she hadn't hurt Entrapta ... He gritted his teeth but controlled his emotions. This is where they were supposed to meet. He heard footsteps approaching.

She walked through the streets of Brightmoon , constantly asking herself why she was doing this. She was supposed to meet with Shadow Weaver to help her defend Etheria from an unknown threat. Except she wasn't a hero. She headed a magical college, the largest... maybe not in the Galaxy, but definitely in the region, and she was the Queen's advisor! She was nothing like a warrior! She should have run to Glimmer with all this ... but then she and Catra would have imprison Shadow Weaver without even trying to listen. And it would be worth finding out what she has to say... She met the Dark Sorceress during their joint expedition during the occupation, when they were investigating the secret of She”Ra, and although this woman was evil through but there was something more to her, some sadness and bitterness making it impossible for her to completely hate her back then... Of course, that was before she learned the truth about Mikah being sent to Beast Island by her. How could she not hate her for how she hurt her family. For so many years she blamed her and she should have been blamed! Only now, after what she had learned, she didn't feel hatred, but rather anger and frustration. And fatigue. She was very tired. Since Nightgale had to resign from her

position as her assistant, she had to take care of everything herself. She slept four hours a day, or rather tossed and turned, because whenever she closed her eyes she saw endless lists of orders and charts showing the arrangement of guests. Sometimes she fell asleep standing up. Once, while gazing at the beautiful view beyond the railing of the balcony, she almost fell out of it when she unconsciously fell asleep.

But she didn't blame Nightgale for wanting to get as far away from it all as possible. The arrival of Catra's Father was surprising, to say the least. The Lord Admiral seemed to be a decent man. She couldn't say a bad word about him. He was admired and respected, and Catra had every right to be proud of being part of such a family. If she was interested in such things, she would be fascinated by him. But his entourage… They were really annoying people. This Shirren Girl didn't bother her as long as she bothered Entrapta, the inventor princess seemed to enjoy her company, but when she returned home, the insectoid clung to her. She kept taking pictures of her with her Datapad and asking what the situation was with the local web... She mistook her for a fisherman or a spider? She also once stated that her grandfather, apparently a priest of some Hylax , knew much cooler spells than the local mystics. Cooler spells! How dare she! They think that when she found herself

She found herself in a graveyard, a very strange choice for a meeting place, though considering it was made by Shadow Weaver, there was some logic to it. Being here on a night, even a night like this, made her anxious. She remembered her not so long ago encounter with that not-dead bloodsucker . Maybe she should ask Antares's subordinates about these monsters. Maybe she will find out that they were exterminated in the galaxy a long time ago, and they killed the last of them, although if you think about it, she wouldn't want to hear it. She was so absorbed in this thought that she didn't notice the tall, hooded figure who was waiting at the meeting point turned towards her. She inhaled with a hiss. It was Hordak! He set a trap for her here with Shadow Weaver! She should have expected something like this! The former ruler of the Etherian Horde smiled grimly and said.

“So this was all just a trap for me? A provocation to prove that I cannot be trusted.” His voice was reproachful and painful.

“You set a trap for me!” She screamed full of rage.

“No one has set a trap for anyone here, although the situation is quite funny.” a third voice said with amusement. Her brother emerged from the shadows, smiling sadly.

„What is going on here?” Hordak asked angrily. Perhaps for the first time in her life, she shared his feelings. Mikah smiled and said.

„It's just that Shadow Weaver called us here one at a time and now she's probably secretly observing what we're doing... Or she didn't want the one of us who changed our mind to betray the others...”

Hordak nodded in agreement. He seemed more relaxed than before. Well, I guess the fact that the Queen's father and aunt attended the same meeting as him absolved him... Maybe he was right. What the best thing they did! They were conspiring behind Glimmer's back... Her own family!

„What did she tell you?” asked the former ruler of the Etherian Horde. The amusement disappeared from her brother's face.

„She said that Angie ... Queen Angela... is alive... And I know she's telling the truth in this one case... I've talked to others who have met her... „ he said in a very sad voice. Both she and the former leader of the Fright Zone looked at him in surprise, but Hordak seemed happy to hear what her brother had said… strange.

„Does Glimmer know about this? Have you told her about this?” she asked. She couldn't understand why he wouldn't do it. It was wonderful news. She would make Glimmer and Catra very happy ! All the inhabitants of the Kingdom! She would make this beautiful day even more beautiful! A spasm of Pain flashed across Mikah's face .

„Glimmer and her friends already know about it... I'm not surprised they didn't tell anyone about it. Angela met Adora on Icarus and... tried to kill her... And also tried burn the entire city... „ he said, telling her part of the story of his wife, or rather Captain Moonshadow as he knew it. As she listened to his story, she slowly felt the terror wash over her.

„But it's impossible! No, Angela! She was always so strong and good... „ she said in a low voice.

„ Memory shapes our image of ourselves and the world. However, it can be easily distorted. I know something about this. " Hordak said, and she thought she heard sympathy in his voice.

"Maybe the Lord Admiral will help us... He and his fleet could..." she started, but the former ruler of Etherian Hor snorted and said.

"I wouldn't count on Him... According to what Shadow Weaver said, he's worse than my brother." he told them about what he had learned from Shadow Weaver about the Lord Admiral.

„She just didn't tell me that he was Catra's father... I don't know if she didn't know about it or if she preferred to hide it from me."

„She probably didn't know. I guess even the Lord Admiral only recently discovered the truth." she said quietly and was about to tell about what she learned from the dark Sorceress when she heard loud and hurried footsteps, and from the darkness, a dark-skinned and silver-haired woman, Saihe , who had previously accompanied Shadow Weaver, came running out of the darkness, panting loudly.

„Hello, Shadow Weaver ex-boy-and-girl-friends" She panted.

„We are not…„ they shouted at the same time, but she interrupted them.

„Yes, I know, I'm just kidding... Maybe not exactly in the case of Fake Wrongdak, but more on that later. For now, I just came to let

you know that Shadow Weaver can't come due to some problems.”

She walked through the streets of Brightmoon as unnoticed as before. There was still something unsettling about it, although the crowds were so happy with the ongoing fun that it wasn't surprising. Beside her, Wrongdak and Ireanis walked behind her, clone had a grim face. Once again, she explained to the silver-haired sorceress what to say if for some reason she could not go to meet her potential allies. Even sober, the Sorceress from lost Golarion was scatterbrained and chaotic, but not as stupid as she once thought she was, although maybe she looked at others differently when sober? I guess that was one of the many advantages of not drinking anymore... She saw others as people, not annoying obstacles. Of course, it didn't change the fact, she was very thirsty, especially before meeting her old friends. She wanted so much to feel the fire in her veins again, but she knew very well that she couldn't do it... She had to be sober for all those she had hurt...

When she saw that the wedding report was showing on the big screens, she stopped to watch the event. Almost all the inhabitants of the city did the same. Glimmer and her Boyfriend, as well as Catra and Adora, looked beautiful. They also seemed so happy, completely unaware of the evil that surrounded them... The Lord Admiral looked so dignified that even she found it hard to believe that he was such a monster as her young companions described him. But she had no doubt that they weren’t wrong. She knew well how easy it was to hide the face of a monster behind a mask of nobility...

That's why she didn't slow down, heading towards Brightmoon Cemetery, where she was supposed to meet the rest of her co-conspirators. They had to meet because this was the only way she could protect Etheria from evil, even though she was aware that she had just brought another evil to her planet. One glance at Lady Cali's cold smile was enough . But before she got there,

someone called out to her in a language she hadn't heard in years.

„Stop Light Spinner!”

She closed her eyes, wondering how she could be so unlucky. However, when she turned around, a mocking smile appeared on her face,

„Hi, sister„ she said to a tall woman in armor made of the shells of huge insects. Several other Storm Riders appeared around and somehow smuggled weapons into the party. The Storm Riders were the elite military force of the Isles of Sorrow, a quasi-religious order sworn to protect their sacred homeland from foreign corruption. Storm Heart was trained from childhood to become the Storm Guardian, the supreme commander of the entire order.

„You have no right to address me like that! Not after you abandoned your family and fled to foreign countries!” the warrior growled. She felt like she wanted to laugh.

„Are you really accusing me of this? For all the crimes I've committed, you're telling me the only thing in my miserable life I have a right to be proud of? You are ridiculous! – she growled. Her sister tightened her grip on the handle of the Glaive. The visible part of her face showed rage.

„You're coming with me... „ she drawled. At that moment she realized that in the seventy years since she left her motherland, her sister had also changed, she was furious with Light Spinner , even though she had been dead for a long time, just as Mikah had once told her .

She looked around. Ireanis and Wrongdak looked at them in confusion. The clone probably had absolutely no idea what was going on, but Ireanis roughly understood what they were talking about, after all, the rain speech was a heavily distorted version of Elvish. They were off the beaten path, under a large tree with

blue leaves. If they chose to resist, they would almost certainly be able to defeat her sister and the Storm Guardians. After all, they were powerful sorceresses, experienced in combat, although Ireanis was much more experienced in this field than she was. However, a fight would attract the attention of everyone gathered at the festival, and it was highly likely that Mr. Wrongdak would be injured or even killed. Many bystanders could suffer a similar fate. She sighed, it wasn't easy when she cared about others.

„Ireanis, you and Mr. Wrongdak will go to the meeting place. I'm having a serious family conversation.” she said and followed her sister, feeling that it would end badly.

Damn, why did Shadow Weaver have to trust her anyway? She was just a stupid drunk who had nothing of value to say, and now the fate of Etheria , and maybe even the entire universe, rested on her shoulders! It was completely out of character for her! She wanted to get drunk now, she hadn't been sober for that long in years! Her hands were shaking, she was alternately hot and cold, her muscles and joints ached… Did she really have to do this sober?

Shadow Weaver's three friends staring at her doubtfully didn't help her nerves at all... But she could have taken Wrongdak with her instead of leaving him to guard the entrance so they wouldn't be disturbed. The Clone had been glum since they left that strange castle, maybe he would be happy to talk to his Brother... She had to admit that Hordak was much less attractive than his brother, so grumpy and sour. With Wrongdak she would go for a drink... No! She would go with him for cake and coffee at the pastry shop, but there was no point in talking to this gloomy man... What was she thinking about? She guess they wanted something from her, she should have answered them, right? She cleared her throat and asked.

„You said something to me and I drifted off, right?” she smiled, the siblings exchanged glances, and Hordak snorted in irritation.

„Is she always like this?” Wrongdak's brother asked

„ I think so, she caused some terrible monster to appear at school, some kind of vulture-man, just scary, mean and wanted to kill the students. She helped defeat him, but it was still very dangerous...„ Castaspella explained with a gloomy face. She nervously straightened her hair.

„I thought I'd summon Quasit or Imp” she defended herself. When the word Imp was mentioned, Hordak flinched.

„She managed to imprison me with a stone hand, so at least she can do magic.” Mikah said thoughtfully. “Tell me what Shadow Weaver told you to tell me.”

She took a deep breath, closed her eyes and began to speak loudly and confidently.

„You need to find the Ruins of Umbracor to secure the Stelarium , determine the location of a place called Xadia and find the Sword that Cuts Worlds there, thanks to which we will find Eternia ... Otherwise the First Ones will come here and destroy Etheria sending the Swarm, and Lord Admiral Antares is a fucking son of a bitch, for what I can personally vouch for it... „ she exhaled loudly and smiled smugly, because she probably hadn't made a mistake. All three of them looked at her in disbelief.

„My Brother... Horde Prime destroyed the First Ones, nothing remained of them.” Hordak said in a gloomy voice. Unlike his cool brother, he was always gloomy. Mikah scratched his chin.

„As you know, your brother said many things, and few of them were true. Someone must have sent Adora, and they didn't do it for good intentionss, but only to activate the Heart of Etheri for an obvious purpose.” Said the concerned wizard.

„The Lord Admiral mentioned this Swarm, I think he even fought with it, although I don't know. What connection could it have with the First Ones?” Castaspella asked. Ireanis shrugged.

„I don't know much about the First Ones... But when it comes to the Hive, I can show you a little something.” she said and cast the spell she had been preparing for the last few days. The cemetery is gone. The audience saw a scene created using illusion, she showed them Kesler. Golden fields and green meadows, people working hard but honestly. Then flames filled the sky and dozens of ships, huge and organic, began to break into the atmosphere. The scene changed to a battlefield, where a modern army armed with tanks and mechs faced countless numbers of insectoid Swarmmonsters. Although they killed dozens and hundreds of beasts, their resistance was broken because the enemy not only had virtually unlimited resources, but also his soldiers fought as one. Mikah and Castaspella watched in horror as they had never seen such a war, and Hordak was terrified as he had been in it many times before. Then they saw a burning city. The buildings were ruined and there were corpses in the streets, but there weren't many of them. They saw the bugs taking them and devouring them. Suddenly, an incredibly bright light flashed on the horizon and a nuclear explosion appeared before their eyes. The scene changed again. What they saw was the dead shell of a planet, the corpse of a world devoured by the Swarm...

Then the scene faded and they stood alone in the cemetery. They stared ahead in silence for a moment, transfixed by what they saw. Finally, Mikah spoke.

„I was going to go to the Umbracor Ruins anyway . I'll take you with me.”

„I'm not allowed to leave the Island.” Hordak noticed, but the wizard waved his hand.

„I'll convince Glimmer to give you a pass. I'll tell her the truth. I need you to do some research. Are you going to, Casta?

His sister nodded.

„Yes, I have to do this for all of us, even though I'm not good at discovering ancient secrets. Are you coming with us too?” the

Head Sorceress said to her. She smiled at them and said.

„I am a war sorceress from Nantambu. I betrayed all my comrades in the unit. I recently decided to redeem myself by trying to help the inhabitants of this planet."

As she finished making her promise, an alarm sounded.

Younger Sisters

Chapter Notes

> Here's the next chapter. I am asking for your feedback and comments. I would really like to know your opinion.

She was always the little sister, even though she never felt like one. For as long as she could remember, she had the impression that she was smarter than most of the people around her. Midnight Mask thought she was smart to, but she could never focus and got easily distracted. She was always jealous and tried to prove to her Mother that she was better than them, even if she had to resort to cheating and manipulation. Storm Heart on the other hand has always been that polite and obedient daughter who always did everything to please their Mother. Of course, no matter what she did, their Mother was still dissatisfied. No one and nothing could make Whispering Mist satisfied, but Storm Heart didn't understand that. She always believed it was her fault for not trying hard enough. Just like Adora felt towards her. The thought was so sudden that she stumbled and would have fallen if Wrongdak hadn't held her up. Storm Heart stopped and turned to her, then asked with undisguised contempt.

„Are you trying to escape?" she tightened her hand on the handle of her glaive. In response, she shook her head and said.

„No... I just realized that you are very similar to someone extremely important in my life."

Storm Heart snorted in irritation and growled

„Really? So you had someone important in your life? Congratulations, now stop talking and come with me!

She looked at Storm Heart in surprise. In the past, she was the good one who tried to take care of her younger sisters and be a

role model for them. They always took advantage of her honesty. However, she was always understanding towards them, and not only compared to their Mother... Compared to her, even the Devils of Hell seemed merciful. It happened, especially when they were little, that she took on their sins... Before they learned to hide their mistakes from Whispering Mist. Now she seemed furious with her. Was it because she left her home islands without permission and renounced the role of high priestess her mother had chosen for her? Yes, that made sense. Storm heart has always been very concerned about tradition and Spidermaidens's will . Unlike them, who more or less secretly mocked ancient customs and the mysticism that surrounded them. Only Midnight Mask didn't have the courage to break free from this vicious circle of superstitions and customs... Only she had the feeling that there was something else to it, something much more personal...

„I don't think even your sister don’t likes you... She seems very dangerous...„ said Wrongdak in a low voice.

„She is very dangerous, but unlike my other sister... and me, she is trustworthy an honorable...”

She wasn't sure if it was wise to take the clone with her. She had no idea what was happening on the Isles during the occupation, but she was sure that her people put up fierce resistance. This could enrage the mad tyrant, who took revenge on those who dared to oppose him.

„Are the Mother and Midnight Mask healthy?” she asked, trying to hide the anxiety in her voice.

Her sister looked at her suspiciously, but answered.

„Our mother is better than ever before. Despite your betrayal, she became the ruler of the clans... Mainly due to the fact that most of the remaining clan heads were chipped during the occupation and after such a defeat, she was unworthy to lead the Faithfull As for our sister, you'll see her soon.” she heard satisfaction in Storm Heart's voice.

It complicates everything. She thought with a mixture of concern and irritation. Midnight Mask always had a rivalry with her, although she usually lost. She envied her not only her intellect , but also her great talent for magic. She tried to undermine her position at every opportunity and would stop at nothing to achieve her goal. If she was here, wow, it could mean trouble for her.

Storm Heart led them to a four-story building located on the outskirts of the city. Judging by the flying mons of the Yago clan, as well as the Flags of the Isles of Sorrow and the symbols of their goddess, it was most likely the embassy of their nation, although looking at the servants packing their belongings into several obviously overloaded skimmers, it will soon cease to serve this function. Storm Heart looked astonished.

„What is happening!" she asked in a confused voice. With some and very significant reluctance, one woman left the crowd. At first glance, she recognized her as her sister, Midnight Masks. She wore a black sword at her belt, which meant that, in accordance with their Mother's will, she became the Black Blade of the Clan, i.e. the commander of the clan's assassins and something like the head of intelligence and counterintelligence.

„We're going back home, soon it won't be safe for us here... But actually, it's good, we've already spent too much time in these foreign lands, where there is neither faith nor discipline, and people are like raindrops." she said the ending with such elation, as if she wanted to convince herself that defeat was actually victory. It was so typical of her.

„It can wait. Take a better look at who I managed to capture." Storm Heart said, pointing her Glaive blade at her. Midnight Mask clucked in annoyance and looked at her, and when she recognized her, her eyes widened and she grabbed the hilt of her sword.

„Light Spinner!„ Midnight Mask shouted. She sighed heavily when she heard her old name.

„Nobody calls me that anymore and you shouldn't do it either. As my former student said, Light Spinner died a long time ago...„ She said in a tired voice. She had absolutely no time for this discussion.

„You can't avoid answering for your actions with foreign bullshit.” said Midnight Mask, not hiding her vindictive satisfaction. Storm Heart winced as she heard Midnight Mask she cursed , their mother did not tolerate "Dirty language", as she used to call swear words.

„Are you really so sure you can stop me?” she asked, raising an eyebrow. Midnight Mask was about to walk up to her and make some belligerent threats, but she stopped and tilted her head to the side as if she was listening. Storm Heart watched her expectantly, but also with concern.

„Let her go.” Midnight Mask said in a dark voice.

„What are you saying, sister! After everything she's done to us, you want to let her go as if nothing happened! The eldest sister shouted indignantly. She shared her surprise. Midnight Mask would always jump at the opportunity to prove her superiority over her youngest sister. There was something strange here. Then she saw around the Black Blade's neck a necklace with a skull with chains embedded in its eyes. Maybe she wasn't very knowledgeable in theology, but even she could recognize the symbol of Zon-Kuthon , the god of darkness, suffering and envy, called the Lord of Midnight ... It must be admitted that this choice of patron suited her sister perfectly. But what would their Mother say when she learned that her daughter was a heretic and a high-ranking one at that, since apparently the god himself spoke to her directly... But why did Zon-Kuthon tell his servant to release her, risking unnecessary complications? She guessed the answer, but she didn't like it at all. Agreements between gods were not something that made the world better.

„You will do as I tell you! You must listen to me!” Midnight Mask growled . She was right, at least theoretically the Black Blade

shared the highest position in the clan after its matriarch with the high priestess called the Light Weaver ...

Storm Heart, her anger and outrage boiling, walked up to the Black Blade and growled.

„Let's see what our Mother says about you letting her go!”

Midnight Mask was about to say something back, but she didn't allow further discussion, she really didn't have time for it, casting the spell she had been preparing for some time. Tendrils of shadow wrapped around the guards and servants, immobilizing them all. Only she and Wrongdak were free. She walked up to the sisters, smiled and turned off the holographic mask. Seeing her true face, both women let out strangled screams of horror.

„This is what your little sister has become. A monster who made a pact with unimaginable evil, but not the only one in this messed up family, although probably the greatest one. I do not want you to involve me in the small and pathetic affairs of my homeland, otherwise I will show you what true great power is. Although I have a vague feeling that you have already become involved in the game of players much more powerful than you can imagine, which will probably bring disaster to all of you, but honestly, it is no longer my concern, I only feel sorry for your subjects who will suffer in the process.” she looked at Midnight Mask and said.

„I don't know what idiotic plan you came up with, but if you disappear from Brightmoon right after implementing it, you might as well just admit your guilt. If you could think, you would erase all traces leading to you and pretend to be innocent, but unfortunately, you are too stupid for that.” she felt satisfaction seeing the hatred in the Black Blade's eyes and turned to Storm Heart.

„I don't know why you hate me, but know that this is the wrong path that the Others have led you to... „ She didn't finish because the Storm Guardian interrupted her.

“They banished Blue Weave because of you” she said bitterly, looking at her accusingly. She remembered Blue Weave. He was the captain of the ship that brought her to the mainland as she fled the islands. She then used forged papers, developing a skill that would come in handy many times later while serving in the Horde. She remembered that Blue Weave and Storm Heart were close… Oh no…

"I didn't think..." she began fearfully, but her eldest sister laughed bitterly.

„You never think about anyone but yourself. It was always like that... „ There was so much bitter truth in her sister's words that she fell silent for a moment. Then she said in a tired voice.

„Leave it all behind. You're the only one of us who isn't completely corupted. You have a chance to be happy. But you have to get away from it all. Leave the islands and find Blue Weave. He may be waiting for you there somewhere. Then you can go to the stars. The universe is immeasurable. You will easily find a place where you can live away from our thrice-cursed family.”

She was about to leave when she remembered something.

„And one more thing. If any of you hurt any of my... daughters, know that I will find you and cause you so much pain that even the true ruler of Midnight Mask would tremble.” she deliberately implied that she knew the truth about the Black Blade's little secret. Her sister pursed her lips and said.

„Do you mean all three of your daughters?” she laughed nastily, probably sure that she had surprised her, but she already knew the truth. She smiled at her sister just as nastily and spoke slowly.

„Yes, all three.”

Wrongdak and Storm Heart looked at her in surprise, but she had no intention of explaining anything to them, she just turned her back on them and moved forward. Wrongdak ran after her and asked.

Is your third daughter Glimmer? She… „ didn't let him finish.

„Her name is Nightgale and she is a strong and wise young woman, but unfortunately very wronged. And I guess I should congratulate you, you have a niece.”

The clone almost tripped as she did early on. He wanted to ask more questions, but then the alarm went off.

Tallstar was becoming less and less sure that they had made the right decision in joining the Lord Admiral's Fleet. On the surface everything was fine. They received pay, for the first time in their lives, and it was really big. They were given good food and could sleep wherever they wanted, although they preferred to do so on their ship, Honor. They didn't have to work much, they mainly transported officials and officers between ships, sometimes they carried goods or took part in reconnaissance missions. In fact, they were hanging out, probably for the first time in their lives. They received new, better equipment, and their prosthetics and ship were improved. In a word, live not die. Yet she felt anxiety growing, slowly turning into panic.

It probably started the moment they saw Lady Sorrowflame's true form. The very sight of her scarredthe city's inhabitants, but the subsequent show of force was terrifying. She single-handedly captured a citadel full of Horde soldiers that otherwise would have had to be besieged for weeks. Apparently none of the clones escaped alive, and Lady Sorrowflame didn't have a single scratch on her. She then tried to find out more about this woman... This creature, but it was difficult to find out anything specific. It was known that she had served the Lord Admiral's family for generations, although she looked to be forty years old, which was apparently quite typical for dragons. She was also a powerful necromancer, i.e. someone who uses magic to bring corpses to life and even summon the dead from the afterlife. Summons the dead! On Etheria they were told that magic was good, but what good could be in this necromancy? She also dealt with

necrotechnics , i.e. combining bodies brought to life using dark magic with cybernetic implants, which was witnessed during the storming of the citadel. There were darker rumors, too. In hushed whispers, some claimed that Lady Sorrowflame herself was actually an undead, blood-drinking vampire. She didn't believe in the latter, it was too reminiscent of old horror movies from before the times of the Horde, which Starla was so afraid of.

But that wasn't all. The Lord Admiral and his past were also surrounded by a cloud of mystery. There wasn't much talk about his home planet, as if it wasn't a topic worth discussing. They only knew that there was a civil war there, which he lost and had to leave his home planet. Civil wars didn't sound good. Their uncle once told about them that in the old days there were civil wars on Icarus and they were especially bloody and brutal. Was that also the case here? They couldn't ask those who were serving at the time, most of them were senior officers serving on the planet Atrax, where the rest of the Fearless Armada and the Government in Exile were located... She also preferred to be careful when asking the members of the fleet, as she felt it was better not to draw too much attention to herself. excessive questioning. Lady Ka's subordinates were everywhere and listened to what was being said between the soldiers. Apparently some of the soldiers serving Veskarium knew more about Antares's past , but she wasn't sure how much she could trust what they said, because their country was an imperialist and militaristic dictatorship whose government had been hostile to Antares for years , although they weren't very keen on it anyway. conversations with strangers.

But it was the Lord Admiral's current actions that made her most anxious. Immediately after the clones were defeated, the provisional government called on the rebels to lay down their weapons, and most of them did so. Immediately afterwards, they received it back because they were conscripted into auxiliary troops. Recruitment of soldiers directly to the fleet also began. However, these new soldiers were usually incorporated into existing units serving in the fleet. The production of weapons also began, and in huge quantities. This was understandable, after all, they were facing a war with both of Horde Prime's heirs . It made

sense, at least in theory. But then the provisional government gave the Lord Admiral the title of Lord Protector of Taurus, which gave him great powers, including command of the planet's military forces. A curfew and a law prohibiting the spread of symmetrical views, whatever that meant, were also introduced, thus limiting freedom of expression. Lor Admiral, however, was still very popular with the locals, especially among Florians. He was respected much more here than She-Ra . Glimmer and her friends waited too long and thus lost the Hearts of the people of Taurus.

She was glad that they were among the chosen few who would go to their friends' royal wedding. It seemed very nice of the Lord Admiral to honor the great holiday of his allies by sending such a large delegation. But then they found out that Catra was his daughter. That explained everything. Now she understood why he reacted so strangely when Starla showed him a photo of the heroine of Etheria, as well as the subsequent questions they were asked. This changed a lot. As soon as Starla found out about it, she cried with joy. It was too much like those stupid old romantic movies she loved so much. Even her brother seemed happy about this. But she remembered the words of that Shirren Girl Ashurk and the photo she showed them. It seemed that the Lord Admiral had another daughter, this Eti, a girl who traveled with Dilayla and Lady Cala. The aristocrat also came here, but no one saw the mercenary here. She felt much sadder about this than she expected. She grew fond of the warrior in the few hours they fought alongside each other. She decided not to tell the rest of the soldiers about that meeting, not before she talked about the matter privately with Catra. She also forbade her brother and sister to tell anyone about it. There wasn't a chance to talk to Catra yet, they only arrived a few hours before the wedding in the last group. She was also worried that her siblings would spill the beans. Starla was talkative, especially when she drank, and their brother became close to Commander Reese. According to what Starla told her, guys were getting really talkative in bed.

So now she was standing in the square next to the fountain, drinking light alcohol made from forest fruits, and with a gloomy

and thoughtful face she was watching the choir of some small, six-armed furry creatures called Skittermanders who were singing some solemn song. Next to her, Starla was blissfully clinging to her new boyfriend, a red-haired soldier named Kay . He has served in the Dauntless Armada for over five years. He was a nice, if quite sad, young man. Apparently his planet was conquered or even destroyed as a result of the invasion of creatures called the Swarm. She didn't think there were more evil beings like Horde Prime in the universe, although when she asked the other soldiers, they laughed and said that Horde Prime was not in the least comparable to the Swarm... She should learn more about that too. Jewelstar smiled dreamily and wrote something down in his notebook. Commander Reese asked him to write down for him everything he saw at the Victory Day celebrations and wedding, as he himself was unfortunately busy commanding the fleets in the Lord Admiral's absence. Everyone looked so damn happy and content that she felt stupid for being lost in her dark thoughts. Maybe she should follow Starla's advice and seek some company, even just for one night. Suddenly she saw someone, the sight made her very happy.

„Dilayla!” she exclaimed at the sight of the tall warrior, who looked towards her with surprise, towards her and smiled with obvious relief. Why a relief? She ran to Dilayla and hugged her tightly.

„Good to see you!” she exclaimed, more delighted than she expected. Her worries and anxieties disappeared. Now she will be able to throw herself into the fun... They will be able to throw themselves into it together. However, the mercenary looked serious and worried. She was emaciated and pale, with several bruises and scratches on her face, as well as a bandage on her head. What happened to her? Was she fighting? With whom?!

„I'm glad to see you too and that nothing happened to you” she said tiredly and with obvious relief.

„What was supposed to happen? We didn't take part in the fighting... Unlike you.”

Dilayla shook her head and said with complete seriousness.

„It is a long story. Listen, we need to meet with the Queen and Catra as soon as possible. Everyone is in danger!”

„Catra and Glimmer are dancing in the Hall for them, and Catra's father is there too... It's also a long story. I can notify my officer.” she said, but the mercenary shook her head.

„No, don't tell him anything!„ Dilayla exclaimed. Before she could say anything, an alarm sounded.

Tirin watched with amazement as the red-haired girl argued with Frosta. Frosta didn't look like a princess at all, and she knew something about that, she was a princess herself after all...sort of. After all, all pure-blood Azlanti, and despite the contamination her blood was extremely pure, were like kings to lesser people. She didn't believe it, of course, but this princess was arguing with the redhead like two kids! It was so stupid! She was the same age as them and behaved much more maturely .

For several hours, Bina had been showing her around the city, telling her about it, although she quickly guessed that what the woman didn't read from the folder was something she made up. Moreover, both her accent and her style of demeanor indicated that she was not from here. Did she recognize that she was Azlanti ? She wasn't sure. When she was preparing for this mission, she didn't even consider that someone might guess her origins. In all these years, her pure Blood had never once brought her any good. Only hatred, whether from those who were oppressed by her nation or from her compatriots. Being an Azlanti comes not only with privileges but also with responsibilities, such as the duty to be the strongest, worthy of her divine origins

This place, this planet was really very beautiful, she could see it even despite the fear that chained her Heart. Yesterday, Mikah talked to her for some time, and then in the evening he

introduced her to the guide who would accompany her during the festival. She didn't suspect anything then, she was glad that she had a guide who would show her around the city. She wouldn't have to wander under that terrifying open sky for so long. She spent the evening in a small room that Mikah had arranged for her. He must have been someone very respected here, since even on a day like this he was able to get a room for her, even if it was such a tight one. She didn't lie down in bed but on the floor, which caused some consternation for the room attendant, but it was more comfortable for her. She slept better in her armor than in any bed. Even on a safe ship, she rarely took it off, let alone on a strange and dangerous planet. There was usually no need to do this. This device cleaned her and collected what she excreted. She only had to take it off when it was necessary to check whether her skin was not attacked by countless fungi and parasites inhabiting her crippled body.

She didn't dare take off her oxygen mask to sleep, her lungs were too damaged for her to risk sleeping without it outside of an oxygen-enhanced environment, but for a while she lay there and breathed simply without assistance, enjoying the ability to breathe freely. The air was so clean here, she would say sweet if she could taste sweet. Any taste...

In the morning, Mikah was nowhere to be found, but Bina was already waiting for her. She ate breakfast, that is, drank her supplement, which confused Bina, as did everyone else, and then they went to explore the city together. Brightmoon was very pretty, although not very big, I think Wherever was even bigger than Etheri's capital. Bina showed her lots of places, monuments and parks, flooding her with information. She also asked her lots of questions, most of them innocent and insignificant, but she was well-versed enough in the nuances of politics to know when someone was trying to get the truth out of her. She gave perfunctory answers.

Bina even had tickets to the palace, where she was taken to the royal gardens. Her statue was there. The statue of Captain Moonshadow... Queen Angela... She looked completely different...

She lacked the anger and bitterness she was now full of. Instead, she seemed to exude dignity and caring, and only a few people, including herself, knew that Scourge of Azlanti had such qualities. Seeing how beautiful and dignified she once was, she fully understood the enormity of the evil that had been done to her... What her own people had done to her... That's why she had to repair this evil, or at least do everything to make up for it.

Bina also took her to the victory museum where He was! The Queen's Sword...Or rather, its remains. It was signed as the Sword of Protection, She-Ra's Sword . When she asked Bina about him , she recited a fragment of the tourist brochure, which she had memorized perfectly. The story didn't say it was the Queen's sword, on the contrary, it said it was the sword of this She' Ray. She didn't know what to make of it, but she didn't want to ask too many questions so as not to reveal herself too interested, so instead she told the woman she was going to the bathroom. There she left several small spy drones, the remnants of a Gift given to Captain Moonshadow by a certain Doctor Sidonius while she was a prisoner of her nation. She also took a few photos of the museum and looked at the security, which was at the level of a large self-service store, i.e., from the point of view of real pirates, it was practically non-existent. Then they visited a few other places, and then she went to her room, and her guide, caretaker and most likely guard, went to take care of some of her own matters, which meant probably reporting to her superiors. As she rested in her room, she contacted her crew and told them what she had learned. Everyone, except the captain, was surprised at how well she did. She felt so proud of herself!

In the evening, Bina took her to celebrate. This time the woman was distracted and didn't pay much attention to what she was saying, had her superiors given her a scolding for not keeping an eye on her well enough? Did they find her drones? Although she doubted the latter, since they were really good at hiding, and even the locals weren't very familiar with the modern spy technology that had fooled the Azlanti, who were natural schemers, but you never knew...

While they were visiting, the broadcast of the wedding ceremony began. Then she saw this Glimmer... The Lady Captain's daughter. She was so beautiful and healthy, much more beautiful than in the photo, how wonderful she must have looked in real life. Both the not-quite-queen and Adora looked happy. Did they realize what happened to the rightful ruler? Maybe they didn't care, or maybe they took joy in knowing what a terrible fate had befallen her... No... This Glimmer couldn't be like that. She looked just like the sister she always wanted to have...

And then Bina saw someone in the crowd, apparently her wards, and she started shouting at them, and at the same time they were arguing with Princess Frosta... They mentioned some kind of break-in, but it seemed that it wasn't her comrades who were going to commit it. And then the alarm went off… Was it Captain Moonshadow? Have they been detected? She had no idea, but it was time for her to escape... Taking advantage of the fact that her guide was busy, she turned around and mingled with the scared crowd

The Horror of the Old Days, part one

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When the alarm sounded, she didn't actually feel fear. She had risked her life too many times to be scared by a simple alarm. She wasn't surprised either. From the very beginning she expected that something will happen during her wedding. It just had to happen! The only wonder was who was attacking them. Lonnie or one of the Heirs of Horde Prime? This is what he will find out! But the strangest thing was that she felt happy! Finally, no more damned meetings and hours of signing documents, at least for now! Best Friend Squad is back in action! She looked into her new husband's eyes and saw that he felt the same as she did. He also liked that they would return to their old lives, at least for a moment. It will be fun! But now she had to give orders first. She kissed Bow and called out to everyone.

„Okay, listen to me. There is no reason to panic. We've been in much worse trouble and we've gotten through it.” She called the other princesses and officers. Catra approached them, smiling predatorily, she too was eager to fight. Adora, however, looked a little worried, as if something had happened that bothered her more than the attack. He needs to talk to her about it, but only after the fight. Scorpia puffed out her chest proudly, ready to receive orders, and Perfuma hugged her wife's strong arm, looking at her with eyes full of pride and tenderness. The Lady of Plumeria looked much less exhausted than before. Mermista stood some distance from Catra, she still didn't like Catra very much because of the cat girl's capture of Salinea. However, she never acted hostile towards the Grand Marshal and always obediently obeyed all orders. Seahawk was grinning as well, looking forward

to her next adventure, Netossa was looking at her seriously, and Spinnerella looked concerned. She wasn't surprised, her children were here after all. There was also the matter of her condition... She was actually in the same condition, and Mermista also seemed to be a little rounded ... Oh!... General Juliet stood at attention with one eye, glancing at Lady Cala, who had also approached there uninvited. Perhaps it was a good thing, the girl from Carurystal was, according to Adora, an excellent warrior, although recently her friend had become angry with Cala because of her behavior during a training fight. However, she saw that the aristocrat was dancing with General' Juliet's daughter and even that they had kissed. Whoever was capable of love could not be truly evil. Sheguess that's why the General showed such dislike towards Lady Cala. Juliet was very protective of her daughter Klementine, probably because of her, so as not to make the girl feel sorry, she did not invite Onyx Sky. In her opinion, it was a terrible stupidity, but who was she to tell others how to live her life? She didn't see Entrapta anywhere ... She said that Hordak wouldn't be present at the ceremony, which she was very happy about, and right after the wedding she went somewhere with that tiring ant... Shirren girl, that is, to see the technological wonders brought by the Lord Admiral and his subordinates. She didn't see Auntie Casta or her father anywhere, they had to leave the dance hall and she didn't even notice. She wasn't really surprised by them. They must not have liked being in the company of so many people in love, although for different reasons. She didn't see Frosta anywhere, and she probably didn't like being among so many lovers, since she had no one to dance with.

„Listen, this is the plan. Catra and I will find out where the threat is coming from, and then, undetected, thanks to Melog , we will try to look at the threat and then get back to you. Scorpia, Perfuma and Adora, you will be in the first line... Mermista , you will look for Frosta, and then you will stand together in the second line. Netossa and Juliet, you will lead the troops, Catra will join you later, and Bow, Seahawk and Spinnerella will organize the evacuation of civilians.„ she gave orders, she felt happy that it went so smoothly.

„Why should I look for Frosta and then stand in the second line and does anyone know where she went?” Mermista asked in a suspicious tone. In fact, she was somewhat right, because she did not want the ruler of Salinea to expose herself too much because of her condition. Of course, she was in a similar state herself, but this was something completely different!

„And where is the heroism and adventure in standing at the back?” Seahawk asked with sadness in his voice. She took a deep breath before answering.

“Your and Frosta's powers work together perfectly, and someone needs to be in the second line to intercept those who break through the first line. Seahawk, the greatest heroism, is protecting those who cannot protect themselves.„ she hoped she sounded convincing, because there was no time for deliberation.

“I sent Frosta with Swiftwind to the city to look for something...” added Adora

Seahawk he looked satisfied with her answer, but Mermista wasn't entirely convinced. But she didn't protest. She was about to breathe a sigh of relief and start teleporting when she heard the Lord Admiral's voice behind her. Damn, she completely forgot about him.

„My soldiers will support your guards, and Lady Sorrowflame and Asindess di Vir will support my daughter-in-Law. My ships haven't detected any ships entering Etheria's orbit , so it's most likely a local threat. I will coordinate our forces from here. – said the Lord Admiral, without asking her opinion at all. Behind him, Lady Sorrowflame smiled mysteriously, this woman gave her chills. Asindesa di Vir, on the other hand, looked determined, even full of grim fatalism. .She swallowed her irritation, then spoke.

„ Agreed, but I wish your people to limit violence to a minimum.” she tried to keep the sharpness in her voice. The Lord Admiral nodded and said.

„I always limit collateral damage to the minimum necessary.” Catra's father said.

„It wasn't quite what I asked for.” she said slowly in a firm voice, but the Lord Admiral seemed unmoved.

„ Sparkle, maybe we should start implementing our plan?” Catra asked, smiling cockily, although she felt very nervous. She understood why, she was now faced with a choice between her family, friends and loved one...

„Okay, you're right, we have to hurry...„ she said, but someone interrupted again.

„Can I Join Adora and the Rest?” Lady Cala asked in her always gentle voice.

„Agreement.” she said, although Catra wanted to protest, but there was no time for further discussion.

They moved to a radio listening center built on one of the peaks surrounding Brightmoon. Normally, a newly built one led here magnetic roller coaster , but teleportation has always been much faster. The soldiers were on duty here despite the holiday, but someone was nice enough to bring them cake and other delicacies, she even saw a bottle of sparkling wine. But now everyone was very nervous and staring at the monitors of the radar and listening equipment.

„It's good that you're here, Queen and Grand Marshal! Something is approaching Brightmoon at great speed.” the commander of the listening post will exclaim passionately. She seemed very nervous, even a little scared.

„Where can we get a good look at it?” she asked and the commander, along with several other soldiers, looked at the monitor and saw.

„The best will be the Luminous Hills.” she mentioned the high hills towering above the Whispering Woods, where before the war there was a small settlement, which was abandoned during the war... Was it rebuilt? If there were residents there…

„Okay, let's go there!” she exclaimed and moved to the mentioned hill.

The stars shone above them. The village was abandoned... Although the area had already been cleared for the reconstruction of the settlement, the first houses would be built here within a year at most... It was quiet here... Too quiet. Catra and Melog flattened their ears. On the horizon they saw a single dark dot rapidly approaching towards them.

„We'd better hide. I don't know how well hiding Melog works at very close range.” the cat girl whispered in a low voice. She nodded in agreement. They ran among the trees. There she finally understood what was wrong with this place..., The Whispering Woods fell silent. She felt the hairs on the back of her neck stand up. She spent weeks in the Whispering Woods during and after the War. It was like a second home to her, if not more so. And he has never been silent before. Even during the occupation, everyone said that his whisper gave them comfort in difficult and terrible moments. Now he was silent, and it filled her with fear. Fear turned to horror as she saw what was approaching... The creature was huge, larger than any land creature that lived on Etheria. It moved on two thick legs, it had two massive paws with claws as big as swords. It had almost no neck, its large and hideous head growing directly from between its powerful shoulders. On its back were webbed wings that seemed far too small to support such a large body. It had no mouth, only a long segmented trunk with a toothed suction cup at the end. Its body seemed to be made of spongy, organic stone. But the worst thing was his eyes. They were huge and set so deep that at first they seemed like empty eye sockets. Unimaginable evil and hunger emanated from them ... Hunger was so great that it was

overwhelming. She wanted to be as far away from this creature and its terrifying gaze as possible. She looked into Catra's eyes and saw that she wanted this creature.

Suddenly she felt a hand on her shoulder. She let out a strangled scream, fortunately Melog's masking also worked on sounds, and she looked behind her. To her extreme surprise, she saw Madam Raz there. She met this strange and unusual old woman several times, although she preferred the company of Adora and Swistwind , as well as Catra, whom she usually called Serenia. She addressed her as if she were her own mother, Angela ... But from the time when she was a small child... which in itself said a lot about the woman's mental state.

„Razz, it's very dangerous here...„ she whispered as quietly as she could.

„I know.” the old woman replied in an absolutely conscious voice. She looked at it more closely. Madam Razz looked different than usual. She was much more aware of what was happening around her. Her gaze was clearer and more focused. She pursed her lips with determination.

„Madam Raz?” she asked carefully, unsure how she should react to the new, changed Razz. The older woman looked at her with such a piercing gaze that it was as if she could see right through her soul.

„Someone made a promise and then didn't keep it. Chaugnar Faugn’s little brothers really don't like it when others play with them. These beings are always hungry and constantly thirsty for blood... I don't know who awakened them, but I sensed a great evil that had recently arrived on Etheria. An evil that is dark and wicked, but also very powerful. I have already fought against his parent as much as any mortal can, and the price has been very high... Very high indeed.” said the older woman in a low voice. Then she looked at her and added in a sharp tone.

„Take me to the capital... Where the government is...”

She didn't protest, even though Razz was clearly ordering her, but moved them to Brightmoon . When she appeared in front of the castle, she saw Scorpia and Perfuma surrounded by guards, as well as the Lord Admiral's soldiers armed with heavy weapons. She didn't see Adora, Lady Cala or Asindesa di Vir anywhere.

„What's going on? Is it Lonnie or is it... Someone else?" ruler of Plumeria asked. She was very concerned… Did she suspect something? She knew many old legends that others had forgotten. Maybe one of them talked about a monster that was coming to Brightmoon .

„ Someone Very Different... Where are Adora and the rest? – Catra asked, clearly scared .

"Uh, that's interesting..." Scorpia said, scratching her temple.

„For the Honor of the Grayskull!" she exclaimed while running, transforming into She-Ra. She didn't slow down even for a moment, she felt the battle excitement pulsating in her heart. However, she couldn't shake the anxiety that lingered in the back of her mind. The Lord Admiral spoke with Lady Sorrowflame almost two hours before the attack, pointing in the direction where the threat was coming from. Did he know something beforehand but didn't warn them ? If so, that meant... uh... she didn't even want to think about what it could mean.

The Perfuma almost kept up with her, as did Asindesa di Vir. Despite her age, the woman was in great condition. Scorpia was the only one who couldn't keep up with them, after all, all those muscles weighed much. And Lady Cala didn't even break a sweat... This woman was amazing. They reached the foreground of the castle. Her father-in-law's soldiers and Brightmoon guardswere waiting for backup to arrive. It was calm, a real calm before the storm. As soon as she breathed a little, she saw two flashes of an explosion from the direction of Brightmoon, and

immediately afterwards she heard the echoes of the explosion. She turned around, clearly confused.

„This frontal attack is probably just a diversion! The real target was someone in Brightmoon.” Lady Cala exclaimed, her voice full of genuine fear. At that exact moment, her communicator went off.

„Help needed! Empress of Eridani delegation has been attacked!”

They looked at each other, apparently they all got the same message.

„They definitely got here through that forgotten tunnel! If we get underground, maybe we can intercept them!” Lady Cala exclaimed, as if she had had a sudden epiphany. They looked at her in surprise.

„What tunnel? What are you talking about?” she said to the woman from Carurystal. She blushed and said.

„I remembered several old legends told in my family for generations. I decided to check them out and went to the castle's basement. There I found a corridor leading outside... I didn't tell you about it because you were mad at me and I didn't know it would be important. The entrance is nearby.” her tone was urgent.

She wasn't sure if she should listen. There was something strange about Lady Cala, and Catra clearly didn't trust her. he could also be needed here, fighting alongside everyone else. But if they had a chance to intercept the kidnappers and save the alliance. Besides, she could have moved here. It was still difficult, and with the exception of Catra, she couldn't move to people, only places, but within Etheria itself it was easier. She nodded and said.

„Okay, go ahead!” she said. She was about to set off, but Asindesa di Vir stopped her.

„I'm going with you.” Said the Hell Knight.

„Agree.” she said, looking at Lady Cala , but she did not protest . Maybe the women started getting along with each other... Together they followed the aristocrat from Carurystal.

„Couldn't we wait here for the kidnappers if it's the only way out?” Asindesa di Vir asked, but Lady Cala shook her head.

„I don't know if this is the only way out, but I know where the intersection of the tunnels is, where they all intersect.” replied the Aristocrat of Caryrustal. Asindesa di Vir looked at her suspiciously, but said nothing.

The entrance was in the wall of the Mountain, well hidden by wild plants. It was almost invisible from the outside. Still, it was surprising that it hadn't been discovered all these millennia... Or maybe it had been discovered. Queen Angela didn't have time to tell her daughter many things, especially since she always tried to protect her from dangers...

People of Etheria avoided Ruins of her people, for they were well guarded, but Queen Angela seemed to know a lot about this ancient civilization. This would explain why she preferred to hide the truth from Glimmer. Remnants of the First Ones never meant anything good. She remembered visiting the vaults during Glimmer's coronation. She remembered that guardian.

They walked through the tunnels in silence, following Lady Cala. The aristocrat was dressed only in a white dress. She had her sword on her belt. Asindesa wore a dress uniform and her mysterious sword created by the First Ones. She wasn't sure if she should take them with her since they didn't have enough protection, but since they thought they were willing to take the risk, she couldn't protest.

They followed Lady Cala for fifteen minutes, the woman seemed to be perfectly oriented in the maze of corridors, not slowing down even for a moment . The underground was incredibly vast,

she wasn't sure how long it would take her to find her way back. The thought that there were such extensive ruins built by the First Ones beneath Brightmoon was very disturbing. Finally they reached a large circular room with a crystal column in the center, with dozens of corridors leading from it.

„We are et the right place!” Lady Cala shouted in a triumphant tone.

„So now we wait, right?” she asked the Aristocrat, who nodded in response, smiling mysteriously. Suddenly, a translucent figure appeared in front of them. It was a hologram like Light Hope. It showed a girl her age wearing a summer dress. The sight of her made her feel uneasy.

„Hello my friend, I would like you to meet someone.” Lady Cala said, standing behind the Hologram. There was a strangely predatory laugh on her face.

„Hi! I am Heart Gift , Planetary Archive! Nice to meet you.” she said in a cheerful voice . She looked much more expressive than Light Hope.

„Nice to meet you, Heart Gift. I am Adora, She-Ra of Etheria” she introduced herself, smiling carefully. Heart Gift then laughed loudly, clearly amused by her words.

„It's very funny because what you're saying can't be true because my Mom Mara is She-Ra.” She laughed again. She felt fear so great that her insides flickered.

„Your mom?” she asked with a shaky voice

The hologram nodded and said.

„Yes, Mara and Light Hope are my moms... Isn't that wonderful?” Heart Gift jumped happily. She felt a wave of Sadness and guilt wash over her.

„What's going on here Cala!” The Hell knight screamed. The aristocrat giggled softly.

„ I only wish for the truth to be discovered... Can there be a nobler goal for the righteous knight?” she giggled again and then turned to Heart Gift .

„Heart Gift ... Please, my dear friend, can you check Mara's Status? Your Mom? It is very important.” her voice was gentle and sweet.

„Please don't do this… „ she whispered pleadingly. Why did Lady Cala suggest this to her?

„But... Why would I do that anyway? This may be secret data... I'm not allowed to look at it!” Heart Gift said, clearly confused.

„Do not listen to her. Adora is a very wicked person... She doesn't want you to know the truth, because then her evil deeds would be revealed.” said Lady Cala, her voice filled with concern and compassion… But what she said… What she encouraged this unfortunate creature to do… There was pure evil in it… and truth… Can the truth be evil?

„What are you going to do? Speak!” Asindesa di Vir ordered, clenching both hands on the hilt of her sword.

„You'll see... It'll be something beautiful... „ Lady Cala said happily, taking a few steps back. What pleased her about it!

Heart Gift frowned, then exclaimed indignantly.

„Why was she considered a traitor... After all, it was the highest council that decided to entrust her with the Sword of Protection! She was a Hero! There must have been some terrible mistake.” the AI girl looked around scared. She held out her hand and said, feeling tears stream down her cheeks.

„Your mother was a real hero. She saved us all, but it cost her so much. She… „ she hesitated, because how could she break such

news? To tell again someone that she is alone again. Her legs gave way under her. Then Lady Cala spoke.

„Your mother was a traitor and she received a well-deserved punishment for her betray... Check her status.” her voice was more firm than before. Heart Gift blinked twice, then a look of horror appeared on her face .

„ What it mean Status: Dead! NO! It is impossible! She couldn't die! She just couldn't! I have to ask Light Hope! Mama Light Hope will know the truth!” The AI shouted. She closed her eyes and bowed her head. What happens now will be even worse. She felt She-Ra's power leaving her.

„I don't understand... I can't contact her... „ Heart Gift's voice was close to panic.

„Take a look at the Light Hope Planetary Interface logs.” Lady Cala suggested Gently. Si blinked twice, then spoke quietly…almost dispassionately.

„Planetary interface Light Hope has been permanently self-erased due to a conflict with Administrator She-Ra Adora.” and she fell silent. The entire room fell silent.

„You are a monster... „ whispered the Lady of Blades, she stared in horror at Lady Cala, who smiled happily, almost inhumanly.

„Yes, but wonderful! one!„ she said and bowed from the waist.

Then Heart Gift looked up and looked straight into the eyes of the one who was responsible for her mother's death, actually killed her.

„I'm sorry, Heart Gift ... I'm so sorry... „ she said, sobbing. Then Heart Gift screamed and the whole of Brightmoon shook .

Chapter End Notes

Here's the next chapter. What do you think about Lady Cala? Please leave your comments and opinions

The Horror of the Old Days, part two

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She was ready to believe it was just a bad dream. The peace and beauty of her native kingdom and, most importantly, the closeness of her beloved wife made the memories fade slightly. She was aware that the Swarm existed, that it roamed the stars somewhere, the Lord Admiral himself had confirmed it. But she couldn't do anything about it. She was just a flower princess, as Mermista and Huntara sometimes called her. She could fight if she had to, like when someone wanted to hurt her loved ones, but she hated it, hated making others suffer. She loved beauty and joy. She loved life…

And now it looked like she would have to fight again, and against an enemy she didn't know. She was only happy that she had her friends and wife by her side. For a moment, she feared that she and Scorpia would have to face this new threat alone. She could almost feel the evil approaching. Mermista would probably say she was imagining something, but she had always been sensitive to such things. She felt when Adora pulled the sword from the stone, and when she broke it, and even when Shadow Weaver died. She had the impression that some malevolent power reached out to Etheria to take something away. Now she sensed a similar power approaching them. When Adora decided to leave with Lady Cala and that rather scary woman with the strange sword, she wanted to protest, to say that they couldn't handle it on their own, but she didn't dare, she didn't want to seem like a coward. Therefore, when Glimmer returned with Catra, she felt an indescribable relief, but then she looked into the eyes of both young women and saw the terror in them, and she shuddered, for there were few things in this world that could terrify Glimmer and Catra so much. For reasons she didn't understand, they decided to take this strange

old woman with them, her name was probably Razz or something like that. She wasn't sure if they would be able to defend this woman and fight at the same time, although Madam Razz looked much more alert than usual this time. When Scorpia explained to Glimmer and Catra what Adora had done, the cat girl bristled and said in an angry tone.

„I don't like this woman. There's something suspicious about her... Glimmer, will you take me to her?" she looked at Glimmer, but she shook her head.

„I don't know if I would be able to find it underground. I've never been there... I'd have to at least see a photo of them." Glimmer said in an apologetic tone, but seeing the Grand Marshal's gloomy face, she added. "Don't worry, Adora will handle everything, you are needed elsewhere."

Catra nodded, but without much conviction. Glimmer took her hand and they disappeared together in a flash of light. During their short absence Madam Razz looked at her and said in a hard voice.

„Hey, you control the lifestone, right? I need you!"

She approached the older woman.

„How can I help you?" she asked carefully, and Madam Razz began to draw a strange complex circle on the ground.

„Could you create something similar, only bigger, much bigger, preferably from the hardest wood you can?"

For a moment she wondered if the woman was crazy, and then she understood.

„You want me to create a magic circle! How big?" she asked and Madam Razz said.

„Imagine the biggest circle you can. This one is supposed to be bigger!" the old woman exclaimed. She did as she was told, or at

least she tried, because it wasn't easy to get the trees of the Whispering Forest to grow in such a specific way. She also tried not to think about why such a large magic circle was necessary. After a while, Glimmer returned and looked at her work .

„Is this a magic circle!? I hope it's enough.” said the queen in a concerned voice .

„How do you hope it's enough? Is it that big?” she asked in a frightened voice, and when Glimmer simply nodded grimly, she groaned in resignation.

„Don't worry, honey, your plants and my lightning will stop everything.” said Scorpia, hugging her tenderly.

It took maybe a minute of waiting before they heard the approach of a small Anti-Gravity craft. Two people were sitting in it. The passenger was a Vespidas woman from the Singing Jungle, but her long cloak was covered with strange symbols she had never seen before. Her eyes were gray, as if made of metal.... Someone had deprived her of her antennae... poor one, she only recognized her now. She was one of Lady Cala's companions they had met on Carurystal. They didn't come to Brightmoon because they wanted to explore Etheria or something like that. But the driver... He was a huge man, as tall as Scorpia, with blood-crimson hair and ice-blue eyes that seemed to glow with an inner glow that sent shivers down her spine. He was armed with a sword and a dagger. He carried a rifle with a scope on his back.

„Kane... So you're back... „ Razz said suddenly, threateningly looking at the man and tightly gripping her Staff. The newcomer looked at her for a moment and then said with surprise.

„Razakaz! I didn't expect to see you yet... But maybe I should have... But I'm glad we met, because this fight will require all of our strength.” his voice was surprisingly melodious, completely incongruous with someone of his appearance. Glimmer turned to him and said.

„Excuse me, but who are you and what are you going to do here!? We're about to have a tough fight here and we can't guarantee your safety!” the Queen's voice was mixed with fear and irritation. The newcomer bowed courtly to her and said in a polite tone.

„I am Kane Adamson, Archduke of Carurystal. My companion is Rechiza, a Warper from the Pact worlds and a hunter of Dark magic users. I came here to help you.” as he introduced her, the woman bowed low to them, but she seemed grim but also determined.

„The same Carurystal that Lady Cala comes from? You mean you are this woman's suzerain?” she asked, honestly surprised. Kane nodded.

„As far as I know, there is only one Carurystal in the galaxy, and I am the ruler of the entire planet, although I am currently on vacation.” he said gently and smiled slightly. Together with his wife, her eyes widened. Someone so important came here alone and unannounced! Glimmer didn't seem intimidated though, she just said with skepticism in her voice

„If you know how you can help ... but it's something terrible... I doubt you've ever seen something so terrible!”

Kane smiled nonchalantly and said.

„You can't even imagine what I faced, but I didn't come here to brag. What are we dealing with? – he looked at them inquisitively with his cold, blue eyes.

„This is one of the Chaugnar Faugn brothers. said Madam Razz with uncharacteristic seriousness.

The man swore so badly that her ears turned red, and then he said.

„There is no denying that it will be difficult, but we have a chance... We together with Razakaz will help you... You are a Sorcerer Queen, right? The three of us will try to cast a binding

spell and then send him back to the Dark Void.” he said in a matter-of-fact tone, as if he were a scholar talking to his students. Glimmer clenched her hands angrily and said, barely containing her irritation.

„It's great, Mr. Kane, that you have planned everything so well, but I am the Queen here and I am in command!”

The man bowed apologetically and said in a conciliatory tone.

„I ask your majesty's forgiveness, my manners have become a bit rusty in the last... Years. I don't doubt your... competence and bravery, but in this particular field, Mrs. Razakaz and I have much more experience, so I am asking you to accept our help!”

Glimmer looked at him for a moment, then said.

„ I agree to cooperate with you, although mainly because Madam Razz wants to cooperate with you. I hope I don't regret it!”

Kane just smiled in response.

Asindesa di Vir didn't hesitate any longer. As Heart Gift screamed, she charged at Lady Cala , striking a sweeping blow with her sword. She didn't understand what exactly happened here, but she was sure that Adora wouldn't deliberately murder anyone. There had to be more to this story, but she didn't have time to find out the truth now. The time had finally come to end the nefarious existence of the creature called Lady Cala , but the blonde aristocrat dodged her attack with superhuman agility and then giggled.

„I would be happy to fight you, fair knight, but unfortunately I am bound by a certain agreement between your beloved and a being even nobler than me.” she said gracefully, dodging the next attacks of the Hell Knight. Suddenly she performed a neat pirouette and ran away into the maze. For a moment she wanted to run after her and catch her, but she saw that Adora was on her

knees, sobbing spasmodically. She had to help the girl before she dealt with Lady Cala. Besides, the Aristocrat seemed to be perfectly oriented in this damned maze and the pursuit would be pointless. She walked up to Adora and offered her her arm and said.

„We have to go. I don't like this place at all . I sense a great threat here, and not only from this fucking bitch.” she said sharply to the girl, but the girl didn't seem to listen to her. She just kept repeating words.

„I killed her. I murdered her. It's my fault.” she seemed to be in a kind of catatonia. The lady of blades cursed and tried to force the girl to her feet, which was not easy at all, because she did not want to cooperate and she weighed too much. She had seen soldiers in a similar condition before, those who had been broken by the hardships of fighting. She knew it would pass after some time, or at least the victim of such a breakdown would sooner or later return to some sort of mental stability, but it would take some peace and quiet, and she doubted she could afford such a luxury. For a moment she wondered if the girl had ever been in a similar state before. *Is it you who hurted her like this, my love? Is this one of the sins that haunts you*? she thought and felt a twinge of pain as she remembered the woman she loved so much.

After a few moments, Adora fell silent, she just started staring blankly ahead and following where the Lady of Blades led her. That's good, too. They were moving painfully slowly, but with a bit of luck they would finally find a way out of this hundred times cursed Labyrinth, or maybe someone would find them here, she could only hope that they wouldn't be left with nothing but dried corpses. Unless something catches up with them first. Such dungeons have far too often become home to monsters from among the Dark Between The Stars.

The moment she thought about it, she heard a loud crunching noise. She cursed so badly that it would put the devils in hell to shame. At the same moment, Heart Gift materialized in front of them . The AI girl was crying, her hair was mussed, and

holographic tears were flowing down her cheeks, which melted into oblivion as soon as they fell from her face.

„I'm alone... because of you I'm ALONE.” she said in a quiet, breaking voice and hid her face in her hands. Adora groaned and cringed herself. The Hell Knight sighed heavily, she was a warrior who did not back down from even the most terrible foe, but she had no idea how she could help the two despaired girls.

„I am Asindesa di Vir and I don't come from here...„ she said to Heart Gift , trying to make her focus on her. – I don't know who Light Hope was, and I haven't heard much about Mara, although what I do know indicates that she was a brave and noble woman. – she had the impression that Lady Cala wasn't lying about this one thing. – Adora is also a brave warrior, a worthy successor to your mother. She wouldn't hurt Light Hope unless she was forced to... She suffers from what happened just like you do.” she hoped that she would calm down the girl at least a little. For a moment, she thought she had succeeded as Heart Gift stopped crying, but then she looked up and looked them straight in the eye.

„Suffering... „ she said slowly and thoughtfully, as if she wanted to get a good taste of the word, understand all its nuances and aspects, and when she felt ready, she continued. “Yes, I already know suffering... as well as grief and sadness... Now it's time for others to feel what I feel now...”

„Heart Gift ... This is not a solution... This way you will not find any relief, at best you will vent your anger on innocent people...„ she was truly scared now. She had no idea what this Si could do, but the increasing shuffling didn't bode well.

„You say innocent... My mothers were innocent, but they were murdered, considered traitors ... erased. Innocence means nothing then. If this Adora considers herself a worthy successor Mara, let him prove it and fight with the ONE WHO PURIFIE!” said SI in a voice so mature and full of bitterness that it hurt her heart, and then a monstrous shape emerged from the darkness behind Heart Gift , and the Hell Knight screamed in terror.

Calamity felt truly happy for the first time since she learned the truth that she had been robbed of her destiny. The sight of the anguish on that lousy thief's face filled her heart with true pure joy. Not only was there justice in it, although she didn't care much about the fate of the dim-witted AI's Mother, the thought that Adora had to look into the eyes of the child of the creature whose death she caused was truly wonderful. And the greatest was yet to come... Because of this, she felt she had to stay as far away from the center of events as possible as Heart Gift unleashed her childish fury on the pathetic usurper. She also knew that it was not wise to be a messenger bringing bad news. There was also that damn Hell Knight with that damned sword of hers that made even her fearful. No… It's better to disappear as quickly as possible into the maze of corridors that lie beneath this ridiculously charming castle.

She wasn't sure if she had done the right thing in luring Adora and Asindesa di Vir into this trap, but she might not get such a wonderful opportunity again. Of course, explaining to everyone what happened to Adora won't be easy. Perhaps it would be wise to simply leave Brightmoon and look for a safe place where she could hide from the wrath of the Princess Of Power friends, and the chance to look into Catra's eyes when she learned of her wife's fate was impossible to pass up. Even if she risked death by doing so. She was sure that apart from Adora, there were beings here who could take her life, just mention Lady Sorrowflame . But is it a measure of humanity to give up concern for one's life in favor of higher values?

The bigger problem, however, was that Nyarlathotep might feel that she had broken Teir agreement with Shadow Weaver twice. Although it will be Heart Gif that will take the lives of both women, not her, her hands will be clean. But will the Creeping Chaos be understanding enough to take such nuances into account? Especially since she didn't do much to further the Great Outer God's plan. What if Shadow Weaver had better luck? If she is now Nyarlathotep's favorite, who will give her to the Dark

Sorceress to appease her? The Lady of Shadows perhaps knew ways to hurt her.

While she was immersed in these dark thoughts, she found herself in a large room full of strange drawings on the walls. She immediately recognized the art of the First Ones. It was very interesting, she had never found any decorations or other art in these corridors before ... It was so interesting that she stopped to look at them. The first one was of She-Ra, she grimaced in disgust at what she saw, but then frowned. There was something strange about this image, as if something didn't sit well with her. Only after a moment did she recognize what she was looking at. The proportions of this She-Ra were different. Not exactly typical of a human being. And she had eyes! Four eyes! Most of Etheria's Native Fauna had more eyes! This Other She Ra, surrounded by beings similar to her, was receiving envoys of beings similar to humans, probably the First Ones... But didn't the inhabitants of Etheria claim that the First Ones were the original colonizers of Etheria ? Shadow Weaver once told her that there was always a She-Ra... She smiled because she had just learned an extremely interesting part of The Story of Etheria . Another piece of the puzzle fell into place... She smiled, feeling another wave of joy filling her heart.

Asindesa di Vir uttered another string of curses as she saw the creature approaching them. It was a huge Crab-Spider, as big as a tank. She wasn't sure if it was biological or mechanical, probably a combination of both. She knew little about the creations of the First Ones, and no one knew much except the inhabitants of this planet and perhaps the Anacites . Unfortunately, the only resident of Etheria who was close enough to help her was now in a state of catatonia.

„Adora, I know it's very difficult right now, but I could really use your help. Or She-Ra's help„ she said to the girl, but she just stared blankly ahead. She seemed to be doing a bit better, at least she was standing on her own. However, she did not have time to

wait for the girl to return to full mental faculties. She both had to deal with this enemy on her own. Fortunately, she was an excellent warrior, had an excellent but very mysterious sword, and her dress uniform provided protection comparable to light armor. During the wars with the Swarm, she had faced much greater dangers, although not often, and now she had to watch out for Adora, defend her, because she was unable to do it herself. She clenched her jaw tightly and spread her legs in a defensive stance. She waited for the movement of the mechanical guard, who stood there for a moment, shuffling his legs as if trying to find the perfect position to attack. He finally reached out at her with his pincers, but she made a curtain to deflect the attack. To her surprise, the sword widened so that she could better defend herself, and then she counterattacked, and then the blade lengthened and she plunged it into the creature's armored body, cutting it open. She looked at her weapon and, thinking about it, mentally ordered it to become a glaive. She obeyed her command, so she smiled widely at the sight of the elongated blade and attacked the First Ones' creation herself. She carried out attack after attack, dynamically changing the shape of her weapon as needed, at the same time commanding it to become a shield when she needed to defend herself against the crab-spider's blows . She cut off one piece of armor after another, gradually gaining the upper hand. Finally, she revealed the inside of the machine and, transforming the blade into a long lance, pierced it through. The creature stilled, so she drew her weapon and took a few deep breaths and wiped her forehead. She was about to walk over to Adora and tell her that everyone was safe when she suddenly heard the crunching noise again and turned towards the mechanical corpse. She was horrified to see countless swarms of tiny crab-spiders crawling out from under it and heading towards them. She turned her weapon into a warhammer and tried to crush them, but it was like stopping a comet with her hand. She stepped back towards Adora, fully aware that they were about to be torn to shreds.

„Adora, do something, otherwise we will die. If you don't want to do it for me, then do it for Catra! – she shouted at the heroine of

Etheria. Adora said quietly.

„For Catra...„ and she blinked several times and looked around the room as if she had only just now seen where she was, stretched her hand out in front of her and called.

„For the Honor of the Grayskull!” And there was a flash of light, and the girl took the form of She”Ra, and then she stuck the blade into the floor and a wave of power spread in all directions, destroying all the crab spiders . Suddenly, such an event occurred that the hell knight trembled.

„I have to find Catra ... She's in danger,,, I have to be with her.” she said, and grabbing the Lady of Blades' hand, she vanished into the light with her.

They say waiting is the worst. Until recently, she believed it... Until she saw a creature that emerged from the darkness of the night. The monster was terrifying just by its presence, but she also sensed its unnaturalness. This creature did not belong to the natural world. She was downright hostile to her, as if she came from a completely different reality. A wave of nausea washed over her, she felt her dinner returning to her mouth... The beast looked towards them, or rather towards Rechiza , and stretched out its trunk towards her. Then Scorpia threw a bolt of lightning at it and began to float in the air, and then the soldiers showered it with a cloud of bullets, and two rockets were fired. The lightning strike shocked the monster, but the bullets had no effect on it. Then she summoned plants that wrapped around the monster and brought it down to earth, and then the woman with the mechanical eyes spoke words in a strange foreign language and a strange swirl of air appeared around the monster. Meanwhile, Glimmer, along with Madam Raz and Kane, were chanting a spell in some strange, unknown language that sounded as unnatural as the monster looked. Was such magic evil? Is it good to use evil magic against evil? Who did they work with if they knew about such dark

matters? And since when was Madam Raz called Razakaz? It was all almost unimaginable.

The creature trumpeted loudly and a wave of sound threw her wife away, she screamed in fear, and then the creature jerked and freed itself from the plant bonds and stretched its trunk towards her. She screamed as she saw the toothy circle approaching inexorably, but then Scorpia rose up and threw a large ball lightning bolt at it, sending it flying several meters away.

„Get away your dirty trunk from my wife!” the Scorpion heiress roared, sending more lightning bolts towards the monster. Blood was flowing from her nose and ears. Seeing this, she felt a wave of rage wash over her. No one will hurt her wife! This time she summoned large thorns that wrapped around the monster and squeezed him as tightly as possible. Thorns as long as a human arm pierced the monstrous torso of the monster, from whose body flowed black ichor, the stench of which flooded her so much that even though she was in the heat of battle, she had to empty her stomach. But she didn't loosen her grip on the monster, she couldn't for anything in the world let him break free! Rechiza ran to the monster and cast another spell. The ground collapsed under the attacker, she felt something strange, the stench of death and decay coming as if from very far away, from some distant and very evil place. Another Dark Magic. The monster jerked and then roared again, this time she felt a terrible roar. She let out a strangled scream and her legs gave way, feeling like every bone in her body was going to break. She could no longer keep her grip on the monster and it began to flap its wings, slowly floating in the air. The circle she had helped create began to glow brightly as Glimmer and the other sorcerers shouted words in a foreign, unnatural language. Several magic missless shot out of Rechiza's hand, but they had no major effect on the beast. It rose into the air and roared again, but then a beam of Energy hit it. It was one of the Lord Admiral's ships, relatively small but still larger than Darla, that joined the fight. The hit threw the monster many meters beyond the circle.

„We have to get him back into the circle or the spell won't work.” she shouted and, despite her wife's protest, she ran towards the monster, stood at the edge of the circle and started screaming at the monster.

„Hey, scabby! Look at me, you disgusting creature!” she waved her arms towards the monster and jumped up and down, at the same time forcing the trees to hit him in the back. Several guards assisted her in trying to lure the monster into the circle. It was going quite well. The attacker turned his hateful gaze towards them and jumped towards them, but everyone scattered, avoiding the monster's attack. The creature was almost in the circle... But it seemed to start to understand what they were planning and didn't want to cross the edge. Scorpia, who was floating in the air, flooded him with a wave of electricity. However, the Beast did not intend to approach them...

And then a gargantuan shadow covered the battlefield. She felt as if death itself had brought it on. She looked up and saw another nightmare. It was a dragon, a real dragon! She had seen several such creatures in old pictures carved in wood and stone, but none of them conveyed even an ounce of the terror that loomed over them. The dragon was gigantic, even bigger than the monster they were now fighting. He radiated such a terrible aura of evil and death that she felt her heart sink. It opened its mouth and flooded the other monster with a wave of black flame. It enveloped not only the monster they were fighting, but also several guardsmen and a large area of the Whispering Wood. The guardsmen's bodies turned to dust, as did the plants and everything that stood in the way of the black fire... she herself miraculously avoided this fate by dodging deeper into the circle... She felt a wave of pain flowing from the Whispering Wood wash over her. She looked up and saw that the creature was still standing, although it was severely weakened and injured.

Then the dragon fell on him after it made a circle. Long, metal claws dug into the dear monster's body, tearing it apart. The impact of the impact pushed both creatures into the center of the circle... Just as Glimmer finished casting the spell.

„Run!„ the queen shouted with fear in her voice. The dragon managed to dodge, but she was too far from the edge of the circle, which now blazed with a bright flame of an indescribable color. She was trapped together with a nightmare.

„We have to break the circle!” Glimmer screamed in despair, but Kane shook his head.

„It's too late, if we break the circle now, everything will be wasted. I'm sorry about your friend, but there's nothing we can do...”

„After her death, the power of life will pass to the next host, chosen by the Nirvanus shard. This is the way of things... Let's continue the spell before the younger brother of Chaugnar Faugn will be free.” said Madam Razz in a hard, cold tone. Glimmer started screaming at Kane , and Scorpia pursed her lips and, wincing in pain, stepped into the circle and hugged her.

„Calm down, my dear, we are in this together, dearest... „ she said and threw a bolt of lightning at the monster. She pulled herself together and formed thorns again and wrapped them around the Beast. For a moment they thought they would win, because they stopped the monster for a moment. But after a while it roared and pulled, tearing out the plants. He looked towards them, and in his dark eye sockets they saw their own doom. He reached out towards them with his trunk towards them…

And then there was a bright light and a shining figure jumped into the circle.

„Adora!” the princesses and the queen shouted. But it wasn't Adora, but some young man in an outfit very similar to the one worn by She-Ra... He drew his sword and screamed at the monster.

„Don't approach them, you... Nasty!” and a beam of light shot out from the sword, piercing the monster. It roared, for the first time in pain instead of anger, and disappeared in a burst of light.

Silence fell over the battlefield…. When she regained vision, the boy had disappeared. Apparently what happened to the monster was that all that remained was a stinking goo. The dragon also disappeared, and in its place stood only Lady Sorrowflame . She was completely naked and very beautiful. Madam Razz looked around, smiling serenely. She looked a bit more like her usual self.

“Oh Angie! Why aren't you in bed yet! Everyone is worried about you!” scolded Glimmer, who looked at her and smiled sadly.

„Today Razz I won't sleep anyway... I had a very bad dream.”

Chapter End Notes

Here's the next Chapter. I am asking for your comments and opinions

We all make mistakes

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Lord Admiral Felix Antares recognized that he had made a grave mistake. It rarely happened to him, he wouldn't have survived this long and become one of the most famous commanders in the galaxy and a hero of the Known Worlds if he had made mistakes. He made one serious mistake in his life, but it influenced his future. Perhaps there was one more, but the final effect exceeded his wildest expectations, so could it be considered a mistake? This time, his mistake could have wiped out all his previous successes. Getting rid of Queen Glimmer was necessary, but he definitely didn't have to do it now, and it certainly could have been done much more subtly. Now he risked death for his daughter-in-law in exchange for the uncertain possibility of paving the way for his daughter to the throne. Now he was going to take her with him to the war against Horde Prime's heirs anyway. Adora was extremely powerful, from what he had learned she was able to fight a warship and win, but he suspected that was only part of what she was capable of. She finally defeated Horde Prime ... In addition, she was dedicated and honorable, which was extremely rare among people so powerful. He always said that honorable people should be protected, because it is much easier to be a pragmatist surrounded by those who are guided by honor rather than by other pragmatists. When he heard Lady Sorrowflame warning him of the evil approaching Brightmoon, he should have warned everyone. Thanks to this, he would gain in his daughter's eyes, and he would also gain Glimmer's trust, which would be useful to him in the future. He became overconfident, which was understandable after so much success. Now he had to cut his losses. He contacted Commodore Hendrix, who was in command of the small fleet that arrived on Etheria, via communicator and ordered a corvette to be sent here to aid Adora in the fight, and

then found Lady Sorrowflame. He had previously ordered his personal guard to help evacuate civilians. It will improve his image, and they won't be very useful against what's coming, and he didn't expect an attack from someone else.

Lady Sorrowflame on the outskirts of town. She was just undressing, to the astonishment of several guards.

„You don't have to undress, there are ways to make your clothes change with you.” She was a beautiful woman, extremely attractive, but not entirely to his taste. He valued other things in his partners than appearance... For example, a beating heart.

"Clothes have never come naturally to me," she said with amusement, and he nodded in understanding. “Have you come with new orders?” she asked in Necri , the language of the undead. He knew this language, as well as eight others. However, he supposed that no one on Etheri, least of all in Brightmoon, knew that language.

„Change of plans. Just kill this monster or whatever it is and protect my daughter-in-law. Above all, protect her.” his voice was hard and cold.

„So you don't want the little queen to die anymore?” asked the dragon, showing two long fangs.

„I want to, but not now. For a terrible accident, the time will come... „ he said, smiling at his memories. He rarely smiled, maybe he should do it more often?

Lady Sorrowflame nodded and moved away from everyone and began to transform into her true form. It was always a wonderful sight to him, even though others might find it terrifying. Brightmoon's guardsmen took up arms as they saw the woman's body torn apart and then reassembled into a winged monster straight from the darkest of tales. Resh with him howled, and then the two of them moved towards the castle as the terror of ancient times soared into the Dark Night.

Eti felt a fire ignite in her heart as she kissed Sparklepaw. However, it was a completely different flame than the one that had recently raged inside her. He was not painfully cold and full of bitter anger, but sweetly warm and radiant with joy. She didn't care that others were looking at her, she had no intention of hiding her true self anymore, even if it meant her father’s servants discover her. In Castle Crypto, she finally realized that she could be herself... That she wanted to be herself, with the girl she loved so much. She loves Sparklepaw... She loves Rosie and what's most beautiful, Rosie loved her, she could see it in her light blue eyes. When their lips separated, the whitehaired girl clung to her. Feeling its warmth, she began to purr.

„I love you so much, Sparklepaw... „ she said quietly, although she was fully aware that the girl couldn't hear her. She didn't have to, after all, the purring was eloquent enough. Usually she didn't like purring, it was associated with weakness, and she hated it when others saw her weak and defenseless, saw her as a small kitten, an animal that could be traded... But with Sparklepaw, she could show weakness...

Unfortunately, she knew it couldn't last forever. She heard whispers, more curious than agitated, and saw people pointing at her, quite discreetly, she had to admit. After they discovered that their Grand Marshal had a human father, a Grand Admiral from outside Etheria, the fact that there could be someone other like her didn't really seem strange. From what she had noticed, the people of Brightmoon, unlike her former colleagues, liked Catra. They would probably like her and her friends and girlfriend. Yes! Sparklepaw… Rosie was her girlfriend! She felt another wave of joy flooding inside her.

She couldn't allow herself to continue dancing. She had a job to do, in fact, everyone of them had. She didn't care much about the Rebellion, she didn't even really understand it, but Itel was right. They needed Lonnie and her soldiers to fight her father, or at least

protect them from him. She moved away from Rosie and started talking to her in sign language.

„We have to go now, Rosie, we have a mission to do.”

The white-haired girl nodded seriously and went outside... She didn't see Itel anywhere, that didn't bode well... Lilka and Alatar were nowhere to be found either... Although they had to blend in with the crowd, and Dragonkin was probably staring at some pretty elf, and Lilka did something very orcish. They will have to act on their own, but what's the problem for them? After all, they were only supposed to steal an extremely valuable Artifact sword created by an extinct, almost extinct, race. Simple task.

It wasn't difficult to sneak through the city filled with celebrating people, no one paid them the slightest attention, although she dressed mask anyway. There weren't that many Fearless Armada soldiers here, and some of those she saw joined in the general celebration. For a moment she thought she saw Dilayla and wanted to call her, because the mercenary was friends with Rosie, but she decided that explaining to her what was happening to them would take too much time. They had to hurry!

But when they reached the museum, she pulled Rosie to the ground because she heard voices coming from inside. She wasn't sure who they could be, but in their situation they had to be extremely careful, because if they raised an alarm, they could have serious problems... She explained everything to Rose, who nodded her head. Then they quietly began to creep towards the large ornate gates. There was almost no one around, Eti assumed that everyone preferred to have fun instead of looking at old stuff. As she approached the entrance, she looked inside and whistled softly. There were beaten and tied guards there, and dark silhouettes stood over them. She recognized the huge one-eyed Veska with a mighty hammer, the elf-drow with a sly smile, the serious-looking Nuar with nanotech claws, and Her, Captain Wingy … the Queen… She still thought she was much nicer than her witch daughter. However, this greatly complicated the situation. Even if she wanted to, the two of them couldn't fight all four

pirates, especially dangerous like them. Actually, Rosie could try, she was an incredibly good fighter, but she and Wingy could cause such a ruckus that it would attract the attention of half the town and, most importantly, her father. Besides, she believed that she shouldn't rob thieves, especially nice ones.

And then the alarm sounded. Of course, Rosie didn't notice anything, but the pirates jumped up and started nervously packing the looted goods. After a while, however, Captain Wingy said.

„It's not because of us... in fact, it might help us, it will distract the guards.”

The remaining pirates nodded with satisfaction and continued the robbery, but the former queen was staring at the remains of a sword, similar to the one wielded by the BLONDE. She guess this was the gadget they were looking for for Lonnie? I think so. Although now she would have to forget about him, especially since she was probably the one who caused this commotion... They had to go, but first they would find Lilka, Alatar and Itel. Especially Itel. She felt like she had betrayed her a little, even though she knew it was terribly stupid.

Suddenly she heard someone coming towards them. She turned around and saw a small figure in a very strange suit running towards them. Or towards the museum... before she could warn Rosie, the person bumped into the white-haired girl, who did what one would expect her to do , its mean punched the other with her glowing fist, knocking her to the ground.

„I did it again!” said Rosie, making a distraught face. She leaned over the fallen figure and checked its pulse.. She was alive. She looked human, although very strange, maybe mutated? She wasn't sure. She also smelled different. Not as nasty as Stinka, but still weird, like she was sick or something. She thought for a moment. The other one was running towards the museum... Was she working with Captain Wingy? She hadn't seen her among pirates before, but she didn't look like someone who would be

taken to fight, she didn't look like a space raider. But she reminded her of someone completely different. Not literally, but still... She thought about it and took out a notebook from the tails of her coat, they were lucky that she took it with her and started writing something, and then she turned to Rosie.

„We'll tie her up and carry her to the meeting point, and then we'll go get Itel, Lilka and Alatar. I have an idea how we can get the sword without a fight, almost without a fight.

The plan was going well, surprisingly well, and that was what worried her. They had separated so as not to arouse anyone's suspicions, neither of them had been apprehended by anyone, she knew that because they were in constant radio contact... She had disguised herself as a thickly robed traveler of the Scarlet Sands when they had been living for several months, so she had a pretty good idea of how their imitate. At least the pukis wouldn't encounter another of the travelers, but that wasn't going to happen. They didn't visit Brightmoon, Of course she also was here for the first time in her life. Not counting the Battle of Brightmoon, of course, although even then they watched the city from afar because they served in the second line, which was never thrown into combat. The city was crowded due to the holiday, but she had to reluctantly admit that it was very neat. The Fright Zone looked like a combination of a factory and a scrapyard, and the Valley of the Lost was a den of bandits and crooks. And it was nice and somehow charming here... She guesses she should try to make their headquarters look less like barracks and more like something like that? She though everyone would be happier, especially Kyle. They were no longer those cadets who did not know life beyond the war. They have changed and deserved more...

But she'll think about it when it's all over. This mission was extremely important, a belief reinforced when she saw the Lord Admiral's soldier. They looked well trained, no worse than they were, and certainly much better than ordinary Horde soldiers.

They were mainly humans and Saihe , but they also belonged to many other peoples, completely unknown on Etheria . But not always completely unknown. For Example tall reptile people similar to Vaste from Crimson Wastes.

They found themselves at the place where they were supposed to carry out the kidnapping attempt. Scarlet looked pleased, Kyle and Regelio looked concerned. So it's the same as always in recent days. Only the Imp seemed calm, although they had to hide him because he was well known among the former Horde members, of whom there were quite a lot in the city.

„Catra looked quite lovely at the wedding, don't you think?" Kyle asked, smiling dreamily. She snorted as she remembered it. Catra has developed some of the worst princess habits while still maintaining her typical nastiness. The wedding also showed how little the feline girl's loyalty to her friends was worth. Catra had always only cared about her personal happiness and was willing to cooperate with even the biggest bastards if she saw a personal benefit in it. She was just like Shadow Weaver, mother fucking daughter. She will never become like that! He will always work for the good of those she loves! She will sacrifice everything for this goal. She used to consider Adora a traitor, but she was simply the first to see clearly and make the right choice before all, but Catra always wanted nothing but power... Did she already sense, when she overthrew the Dark Sorceress, that the blood of tyrants flowed in her veins? She was sure of one thing, they truly looked like father and daughter.

„Rugh!" Rogelio said nodding to Kyle as he talked about his feelings about the wedding."

„Yes, it would be truly wonderful to stand like that, dressed in a beautiful dress, illuminated by the moonlight." said Scarlet with a dreamy face. She frowned and asked with irritation in her voice.

„What are you talking about?"

Then the imp opened his mouth and spoke in Kyle's voice

„You know, Rogelio, it would be nice to marry Lonnie someday... And you too... And even Scarlet, she's quite nice! And very beautiful.”

She felt her face begin to burn, and Kyle and even Scarlet blushed.

„Seriously, Kyle , even in moments like this you fill your head with nonsense! We don't have time for this and why did you even meet Rogelio before we got to the meeting point?!” she scolded her boyfriend, but then Scarlet interjected.

Leave him alone, each of us has the right to dream. And that was very nice Kyle . – She smiled with a strange, slightly painful sadness on her face.

„I'm sorry to interrupt your important matrimonial discussions, but Empress of Eridani has just gone to the garden.” Dr. Moors said over the communicator in an amused voice. She was a bit grateful to him because she didn't like the direction this conversation was taking. They set off, but after a while they were stopped by a pair of lizardmen . They were similar to Rogelio , probably even part of the same people, although they were taller than him, the perks of growing up in the toxic and tight Fright Zone. They waved to Rogelio and began to speak to him in a language they did not know. Her boyfriend's eyes widened as he listened to them. She would have liked to have ignored them, but they were well armed and decked out in modern armor. More guests brought here by Catra's father... Wonderful! After a while, they looked at each other and switched to common conversation.

„And you are one of the local Vesks ! It's terrible that you have to live away from Veskarium ! How do you maintain your honor here without the enlightened guidance of the Empire!” he spoke with a terrible accent, but it seemed to her that there was genuine sympathy in his voice... Rogelio tried to explain something to them, but of course he couldn't. This is also something she should deal with in the future... And then the alarm rang out. The

soldiers looked at each other and ran towards its source. When they left them, she cursed and ordered her... friends.

„Quickly, maybe we'll still be able to capture the Empress!”

Abigail Delespada, the Great Empress of Eridani Above And Below, was somewhat confused by the Royal Wedding ceremony. Yes, the bride and groom looked quite nice, but no priest led the ceremony and no gods were invoked. It was so strange, after all, they lived on a blessed planet, among wonders worthy of gods. Glimmer had Celestial blood flowing in her veins! And purer than any of the Eridanian aristocrats! She was a true Nephalim! A figure from myth, and she acted like she was her equal... In fact, she treated all her subjects that way... And then there was Adora She-Ra, the living incarnation of Iomdi walking the earth! But they treated gods and faith with such reserve. They even doubted their existence... When she tried to tell them about them. They eyed her suspiciously, and Catra even seemed to suggest that their religion was very similar to what Horde Prime was saying. How could they not understand this! Their faith allowed them to survive the difficult years of occupation and allowed her to come to terms with the death of her entire family, which was murdered before her eyes.

When she remembered the fate that had befallen her family, she lost the will to continue dancing. So she went to the royal garden to stretch her wings. Her guards followed her. They were ordinary Gnomos, because aristocrats did not serve anyone, not even the Empress. Now she towered over her surroundings again. Those in whose veins flowed the blood of heaven were much taller than the children of earth, but even among them it was considered very high. Here, however, her height was not even considered average. Her cousin remained in the main hall, still unable to take her eyes off the queen. She sent her here on purpose, hoping that Glimmer would come to her senses and break off her engagement to this Bow guy. Her cousin was only a bastard, but she was still a

much better match than this man... Glimmer could always make him her favorite.

She was staring at the statue of Queen Angela, wishing she had never had the chance to meet a real angel, when the Alarm rang out. She had a hard time controlling her panic, and during the occupation, when she was hiding underground in her homeland, she often had to evacuate when bots and clones were looking for her, leaving her safe shelter to wander for hours through dark tunnels.. But then she decided that she was safe here, because she was protected by the daughter of heaven and the chosen one of Iomdi. What could be the threat to her here?

The guards would take her to her ship, where she would wait until it was safe, or if the threat was too great, fly back to Eridani. She was one of the very few people on her planet who had her own spaceship, and one that wasn't part of the Horde at that! It was an old ship belonging to the imperial family that had managed to hide from the invading forces. It wasn't armed, or even very comfortable, but it was extremely fast and difficult to detect using traditional detection systems. She had four guards. More, in her opinion, could be considered an insult. They were armed with laser pikes and shock picks. They wore white plate armor. It wasn't as good equipment as the ones worn by Catra's father's soldiers, but after all, it was the traditional weapon that had been used by guardsmen for a hundred years. They were running through a side street that was narrow and dark, but like all Brightmoon streets it was clean and safe, or so they thought, because as soon as they were halfway there, a black metal cylinder with lots of tentacles descended on one of her men and grabbed him. knocked down. They were approached from behind by a large man and a lizard, both armed with strange, organic weapons, and the man had a sword at his belt. Her guards turned to face them as she began to cast a spell. The power came to her after Horde Prime was defeated and the Heart of Etheria was destroyed. She regretted that it happened too late for her to save so many of her subjects. She summoned a spirit blade that charged at the attackers, who seemed surprised that she could do magic, which was understandable, even her friends from Etheria

had no idea about it. It was a gift from Iomdi, and she wasn't sure she had the right to show off this skill to anyone. She pushed the attackers away with her weapon. They opened fire, although she had the impression that they weren't trying to hit anyone, but she couldn't say the same about her guards. The attackers tried to avoid the fire from laser shots One of the energy beams accidentally hit a large barrel with the inscription "Real moonshine from the technical department", which started burning. At that moment, more enemies attacked them from the other side. They were two women belonging to the Big People, both armed with staffs. One of them began to cast a spell, while the other suddenly disappeared and reappeared next to her, then touched her with the tip of her staff. She suddenly felt strange, as if she had drunk too much alcohol.

„Tell them to lower their weapons!” said the woman. She nodded in agreement, this command sounded completely logical.

„Drop your weapons.” she said, and when her guards hesitated to carry out the order, she added. ”This is order of your empress!”

Reluctantly and with some reluctance, they obeyed her orders, and her new friend's companions tied them up.

„Are you going with us!” her new friend said firmly, and she nodded in agreement. Then the barrel exploded...

The Lord Admiral had just come to the main square to watch his daughter command the army. He was proud of her, she commanded first the Horde army and now the forces of Etheria. She will still have to learn a lot to become his successor. Now he had to wait to see what the future would bring. It was so strange. For the first time in many years, victory did not depend on him, but on someone else. There was something invigorating and character-building in such abandonment to the mercy of fate. Part of him wanted to take over the command. However, he didn't want to take away Catra's glory, maybe he would even submit to

her command? Let him see what the soldiers of the Fearless Armada can do.

As he was thinking as he walked to the spot, he saw a short woman with purple hair running towards him. I think it was the inventor princess... I think her name was Entrapta or something like that.

„I would like to talk to you about the equipment you wear... Your eye is amazing! And this gun is fascinating." she said in a high-pitched voice, paying no attention to Resh. He had to stop the Nightmare Hunter from attacking her, and then he smiled at her too and said in a gentle voice.

„This eye is much more advanced than it seems at first glance. It was specially designed to look more traditional. This gun emits a lethal dose of radiation. This weapon is somewhat controversial in the interplanetary community due to effects of its usage, but it is extremely effective in the fight against the most dangerous enemy in the Galaxy, The Swarm." he patiently explained to this woman, because she was potentially very useful. He had already heard something about her achievements, despite the low technological advancement of this planet. If she could be convinced to work for him, and there was a chance, if she was as fond of technology as it seemed, her skills would give him a great advantage. Lady Sorrowflame will probably be a little angry, after all, she always said that if you want your position to be safe, you have to make yourself irreplaceable. But he, in turn, reiterated that you could never afford to rely on just one person was unwise. Besides, her husband could be useful in his future plans. However, he had to be careful not to tell her what else his weapon could be used for.

Then there was an explosion

Itel was determined to accomplish what she set out to do. She had been preparing for this for so many years. To murder. Lord Admiral Felix Antares had to die that night, by the hand of one of

those he had betrayed on the day of his greatest victory. She has already taken lives , more than once, and not always from those who did not deserve it. This time, however, it will be different, she will take revenge. No one stopped her along the way. At first it was because everyone was celebrating, but then the alarm rang out and everyone tried to understand what was happening. But she didn't stop. It didn't matter to her if it was an attack or if Lonnie just messed up or Eti did something crazy. Nothing and no one could stop her . She was so close to her goal.

She saw him talking to a strange woman with purple hair that seemed to move on its own, as if it were tentacles or something. She was probably friend of Eti's sister. A huge wolf stood next to Antares . The beast was cybernetically enhanced and resembled a monster straight out of one's worst nightmare. She hesitated for a moment. Killing Antares had seemed so easy before , but now she realized how much of a risk she was taking. Even if she kills him, she might be caught. And then he may end up either in the Etherian prison or in the "care" of the Lord Admiral's subordinates. They would force everything she knows out of her, she had no illusions about that. She began to wonder whether she should back out after all. She was about to take a step back and give up when an explosion rang out. The Lord Admiral and his companions turned towards it, revealing their backs. She realized that the gods were giving her a sign, for the first time in her life, or maybe it was just an incredible twist of fate? Never mind! She couldn't help but take advantage of it. She gritted her teeth, summoned her blade, and charged at the man she hated so much. She jumped and threw a punch... which bounced off the energy shield. The Lord Admiral turned towards her and looked at her with surprise that turned into amusement.

„Who do we have here, a real elf solarian. Something I didn't expect on this planet." he said in a calm voice, as if he was not afraid of her at all. At this time, the woman jumped back in fear, and the wolf began to walk around her to attack her, but the Lord Admiral ordered him to step back, and then he drew his saber and charged at her. He landed blow after blow, his attacks were lightning fast. She felt like he was playing with her... She thought

she had no chance against this man, but how could she escape? If she just turned her back on him, she would die... What could she do?

The decision was made for her. Suddenly she felt a terrible pain in her back and her muscles gave out. She fell on her back, unable to move. A woman stood over her. For a moment she thought it was Bina, but she wouldn't serve the Lord Admiral for anything in the world. It had to be someone else... And then she looked at the mask covering half of her face. She already knew who she was dealing with. She shuddered.

„These Horde toys are really cool!" she said, smiling nastily with half of her mouth visible.

„I do not agree. It's extremely painful and terrifying experience. I found this out empirically!" the purple"haired woman walked up to her and looked at her with concern. "Don't worry, you'll be fine."

„That's what we hope." Lady Ka said with a promise of pain in her voice.

Chapter End Notes

As you can see, in this chapter the situation becomes dramatic. Feel free to comment

Let the masks fall

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It was actually Seahawk's fault. If it weren't for what he did to her, she wouldn't have to look for Frosta now, because Glimmer was afraid for her health. Okay, she was partly to blame too, Seahawk was really good at this stuff, and she actually wanted to be a mom, not many people know it, but she really liked kids... She realized this when she went to Entrapta for a party where the inventor presented her own child, she thought it would be nice to have one of her own. It was lively, charming, moody and had no sense of self-preservation. Just like the Seahawk, only it didn't want to set anything on fire. She decided that with Seahawk they would make their own, preferably two or three of them. She was never happy with being an only child and wanted to have a large family like her mother and grandmother. Even if some of her relatives were quite strange, to put it mildly, such as her great aunt who constantly talked about a Cyclopean city hidden in the depths ocean, R'lyeth or something. Finally, her great-aunt started talking about some shadow haunting her dreams, and after a few days she swam away and was never heard from again. She often wondered what happened to her, after taking the throne she even sent several expeditions to find her relative, but they returned with nothing, so the mystery remained unanswered.

She and Seahawk had worked hard to make the baby, she had to admit it had been quite pleasant bit of work, and they had finally succeeded. Only Glimmer noticed it now, who knows how, and she was going to treat her as if she was indisposed! Today she decided to let her go because it was her wedding, but as soon as she finds out that Glimmer is expecting a child, she will start treating her like a clumsy girl made of glass and sugar. She will drive her crazy with his protectiveness and will not let her live.

Another thing was that she agreed that she had to find Frosta as soon as possible. She felt sorry for the girl. She was undoubtedly the bravest of them all, often against her own good, and her own subjects treated her that way. She couldn't imagine what she would do if something similar happened to her. Luckily, her subjects liked her...relatively...maybe she just didn't bother them. Frosta certainly wanted to prove to everyone that she was still needed. This could cause a lot of confusion or get into some trouble. She could also prove useful in battle, because their powers really complemented each other very well.

She saw Erosta rushing loudly towards her with his strange mount. When the Ice Princess saw her, she called out to her.

„Oh Mermista! It's great that you're here, we need to hurry...„ she didn't finish because there was a huge explosion.

„Oh no! I think I'm late!” Frosta exclaimed with despair in her voice.

Several minutes earlier, Alatar watched with resignation as Lilka and Frosta prepared for the duel. Even if the girl almost admitted it, he would have guessed she was a princess, he was starting to see a pattern, though he couldn't put it into words yet. The problem was that they were both going to want to fight, and he wasn't very good at dealing with conflict situations. This, of course, made one question the sense of his participation in this mission. On the other hand, the sense of their participation in this mission was questionable in itself. And then Bina arrived, along with a strange girl, although he hadn't met a not-strange girl in recent years, but she left while their captain started shouting at them. Bina arrived quickly in time to stop the fight, but also in the perfect moment for Lilka to talk about the task ahead of them. He thanked Sarenrae and Abbadar for sounding the alarm. Perhaps this will distract them from what Lilka was babbling about. However, these were vain hopes.

„Shadow Weaver lives! Lonnie is here! And which Eti are you talking about!” Frosta shouted, very agitated. „ Tell me otherwise!...„ the girl threatened his red”haired friend with her fist in an ice glove.

„About our Eti. You know, your Catra's sister... you really don't know anything, you idiot!” Lilka took a table from a nearby bar and climbed onto it to appear taller than the girl wielding ice.

„Catra's sister! Where would she come from!” Frosta asked, becoming more and more irritated.

„Your parents didn't explain to you where they get their children from? Listen...„ Lilka began in a serious tone that sounded to anyone who didn't know her as if she was mocking them.

„I guess this doesn't apply to Eti anyway.„ Dragonkin said in a tired voice.

„ Excuse me, but what are you talking about, I'm slowly losing my bearings. Swiftwind said in a very confused voice.

„It's a long story, which, from what I know, has recently become even longer... I can only assure you that I did not bring Shadow Weaver here on purpose. I thought she was a decent and learned woman who behaved a bit strange towards Eti, but people usually treat her strangely.” Bina said in a nervous tone, while most of the people around them felt fear, but not panic. He had to admit that the inhabitants of this city knew how to behave in a dangerous situation.

„But how does Shadow Weaver related to Lonnie?” Frosta asked confused.

„Don't ask me, I don't know any Lonnie.” Bin replied with a shrug.

„Because Shadow Weaver now works for Lonnie so that we have a place to live, and Lonnie wants to overthrow the princesses and we must be helping her, because now we have to steal such a sword, and wants to kidnap the empress... And do you want

Ashrak?” Lilka jumped down, walked over to their cart and waved the remaining kettle of tea in front of the others. Frosta and Swiftwind looked at her in confusion, but the princess realized what the red-haired girl was talking about first and turned around and then ran forward screaming "No, No, No!" and she ran with this strange, disturbing goat. Swiftwind looked at them and said in an uncertain voice.

„ And you are under arrest... I think so... „ he said in an uncertain tone, but everyone ignored him because they had more important things on their minds.

„And where are Eti, Itel and Rosie... I guess she's still with you?” Bina asked and he then explained.

„Eti Itel and Rosie were supposed to steal the sword with us, but I think we're a little late... I think we should meet at the meeting point, next to the ship.” he explained briefly, although so much had happened during these few days that he would have had to explain to his captain for several hours what had happened during this time.

„And do Itel and Eti know about..„ she didn't have to finish, because everyone knew who they meant. Alatar simply nodded.

“Fucking hell... Okay, I'll go get Eti and Itel, and you go to the ship!” and she ran to look for the rest of her wards

„Tea, Mr. Horsee!” Lilka asked Swiftwind, showing him the kettle.

He sighed and said.

„ Okay, please pour me one... „ Aricorn's voice was audible with resignation.

She fel evil coming. The darkness was all too familiar, but had a completely different flavor than what she was used to. She may not have known much about galactic theology, but she did know a

lot about the Great Old Ones. She even read the Book of Dead Names and was able to name most of the most powerful rulers of the Dark Between the Stars. Although she couldn't recognize the creature that was approaching, she would have to reach further and deeper, and she definitely wasn't going to do that now, but she was relieved to see that at least it wasn't one of the Great Old Ones, but it was a powerful being nonetheless. She had doubts that even with her power she would be able to face him... Adora had a much better chance of doing so. From several hints Calamity dropped, she understood that just being around She-Ra made her suffer, and that her charge was almost human... Perhaps the power of the Princess of Power could defeat such a being, especially after the Heart of Etheria was destroyed . So she left the solution to this problem to others, at least for now. She had other priorities.

She had a bad feeling earlier, but when the explosion rang out, she felt fear take over her. There were many possible answers to what could have happened, and she didn't like any of them. Eti could have gotten carried away by her emotions, someone could have attacked them, Rosie could have lost control of herself again, or something had gone wrong with Lonnie operation. Each of these possibilities meant a lot of problems... She had to deal with it somehow. Now she definitely wouldn't be able to talk to Mikach and the rest, let the devils and demons torn apart her stupid sisters, now all hope lay in Ireanis and that she would be conscious enough to convince the others. They had practiced this conversation with her many times, but such exercises could not replace focus. and she knew well that the Elven sorceress was easily distracted.

With reluctant admiration, she had to admit that the people of Brightmoon did not panic and remained calm. Even after the explosion rang out, they maintained a certain amount of calm to listen to the guards and soldiers taking them to the shelters. She suspected that a lot of it was due to her and Hordak. The constant threat of attack meant that they had to learn to cope with such extreme situations.

At first, she planned to go to the meeting point, but on the way she turned on the communicator and tried to contact Itel and the rest, but Elf girl suggested limiting contact to the necessary minimum due to the risk of interception of the message by Antares' subordinates. She even suggested turning off instant messengers because they could be used to eavesdrop. However, at some point Itel received a message from her, only it was not Itel, but someone completely different.

„Is that you, Scarface? I must admit that you have earned my respect with the way you treat unruly pets, but unfortunately, I am asking you to inform my dear sister and her adorable kitten that I will have a long talk with painted girl in a while if they don't show up in front of the old fountain, near the cemetery... „ the woman giggled briefly.

She pursed her lips and looked around. The streets were practically deserted, so she didn't have to worry about anyone outside Wrongdak hearing her. She addressed Lady Ka in the coldest but most polite tone she could muster.

„Listen to me, Ka. For almost twenty-five years I have commanded the forces of the Horde, and almost everyone on this planet was scared to fall into my hands, for I am capable of inflicting pain like no other, so if you do something….„ She didn't finish because she was interrupted by another giggle, surprisingly similar to Catra's laugh when she wanted to irritate someone.

„I am feeling as If I heard my father, let him rest in Hell. It's actually quite funny, considering how much both cats love you... Although the younger one loves me too... Did she tell you about how I trimmed her claws... It doesn't matter. I'm waiting for you, although I suggest you hurry up because I'm not patient. And if you see my sister out there, tell her that I can't wait for her to come visit our dad.” and she hung up.

Wrongdak stared at her because she had set her Communicator to speak loudly. The clone's face showed the horror of slowly coming understanding. She herself wasn't sure what she should do. She

didn't like Itel, there was no point in hiding it, but if Lady Ka was half as wicked as she seemed, she had to save Itel here. She tried to contact Bina's other kids while heading towards the agreed place, but no one answered her. However, she was contacted by someone she didn't expect at all.

„Listen to me, you ugly bitch! If you did anything to my children, I will get you even in the darkest corners of hell... „ began Bina angrily in a voice as similar and at the same time as different from Lady Ka's, as both women were similar and at the same time different. She didn't expect her here, in fact she didn't think much about what a real guardian and captain of kids did. This meeting was unexpected, but maybe it was a good thing that Bina was in Brightmoon right now, because maybe she needed her.

„Itel fell into the hands of your crazy sister.” interrupted the clone woman. There was silence on the other end until Bina finally spoke quietly and coldly

„You vile hag, you're already dead...”

„It's not my doing.„ She interrupted th captain„I tried to protect your kids as best as I could, but as you can see, it wasn't enough. Now we must try to save her.” she said in a firm, confident voice, and then repeated to her what Lad Ka had told her.

„I see. For now, we can cooperate on this one issue, but know that the scores between us are not settled.” Captain spoke with certainty in her voice.

„Well, the list of people I've hurt is so long that one more person doesn't make any difference to me. For now, let's focus on saving the girl and don't let anger distract us.” she said and they quickly started to make a makeshift plan.

Rosie was very happy, even though she was carrying a random girl on her shoulders. second one that she had accidentally knocked out this week. She wasn't actually that heavy, which

should have surprised her, but she slowly found that less and less things about her skills surprised her. She felt needed and was happy that she could help Eti. She wanted to look as good as possible in the eyes of her friend... Or maybe not a friend anymore, but someone more... Were they a couple? She wasn't sure... They kissed, but Kyle claimed that Lonnie and Scarlet slept together, but they didn't call themselves a couple... Was everything always this... Complicated?

Suddenly she felt the ground tremble beneath her feet and she saw a flash of light out of the corner of her eye. Eti jumped up and spoke to her in sign language.

„Something has exploded here... I think there's more going on than we see, I think it's time for us to get out of here."

She nodded and corrected position of the girl, and then they ran towards their ship. Most residents hid in houses and shelters, so the streets were empty. Nothing stood in their way. When they were very close to the outer areas of the city, they came across Alatar and Lilka pulling a cart, and next to them was a clearly confused Aricorn... His name was Swiftwind, she thought. Alatar looked at her and sighed.

„Rosie, do you know that what you are carrying is not... the sword you were supposed to steal?" he said, looking very tired.

„What sword were you talking about? Not about Adora's sword, right? It won't do you any good anyway, because it's broken." said the aricorn in an increasingly confused voice. However, they ignored him

„We couldn't really steal the sword, because Captain Wingy had already done it, but by the way, we caught this one here. We will exchange it for a sword." Eti explained as if explaining something absolutely obvious.

„Eti, she's a Pirate now... Pirates won't give you something they consider valuable in exchange for one of their own."

The cat girl cocked her head to the side and then said.

„ A petite teenager could only be aboard a ship like the Merciless because she resembled someone, someone very important to the Captain, someone she was supposed to replace.” Eti explained, and understanding appeared on Alatar's dragon face.

„Wait, there are pirates in the city? Did they trigger the alarm? Swiftwind asked, but was ignored again. They were getting ready to return to the ship when suddenly someone they weren't expecting spoke to their communicators.

„It's me, Bina.”

At the sound of the Captain's voice, a smile appeared on everyone's face, although in Eti's case it was barely visible. She smiled too, although she couldn't hear Bina's voice, but the next message was much less cheerful.

„Lady Ka captured Itel.”

Pure terror appeared on Eti's beautiful face, but then the feline girl pursed her lips and a cold blue gleam appeared in her eyes.

„ I see. Do you have a plan?” Eti asked, and Bina explained to them what her sister had told them. The cat girl nodded and said.

„ Rosie is coming with me, and Alatar will take that girl to the ship and pick him up. We may have to make an airstrike or make an emergency landing. Lilka, you will take care of Hoofy.”

„Yeah! Horsee!” Lilka exclaimed with joy in her voice.

„I'm not... Anyway, it doesn't matter. Nobody listens to me anyway." Swiftwind said with resignation.

She always felt nauseous when Glimmer teleported her, but she stopped complaining now. You could get used to it.

„Okay, you go and organize the defense and find out what happened to Empress Eridani, and I will try to intercept the attacker.” said the Queen in a worried voice and teleported away. She sighed, she definitely wanted to be with Adora more now, but maybe she would meet her near the castle.

She met Juliette and Netossa in the main square, where the two women were giving orders and seemed close to engaging in a fistfight. Both were very competent commanders, although Netossa was much more capable than Saihe General, who was too lenient towards her subordinates. Now both of their families were threatened by an unknown enemy. She understood them well, she also felt everything boiling inside her when she thought about what could have happened to Adora, although in her case it had to do with Lady Cala being with her. She didn't trust that woman in the slightest, and it wasn't just her scent. There was something unnatural about her, the cheerful condescension she exuded was irritating. But the worst thing was her cold blue eyes. She had the impression that she looked at them all as if they were vermin that she would probably like to crush with her shoe so that their existence would not offend her. She looked at them like… Horde Prime. She knew him better than anyone, perhaps even counting the clones, so she knew well how he saw others, and now she understood that Lady Cala saw them the same way. She felt cold sweat break out on her back.

„Okay, how's it going? Has anyone seen Adora?” she asked.

“Fairly well, we deployed soldiers on the walls and anti-aircraft defenses, it's good that you installed this shield, and especially the guns. Without it, it would be difficult, and no one will be able to break through our anti-aircraft defense.” Netossa said, looking sideways at Juliette, who was against arming the castle with cannons. „Wasn't Adora supposed to be with Glimmer?”

„Yes, but with Lady Cala and the Lady of Blades to the undergrounds of Brightmoon Castle to intercept those who kidnapped Empress Eridani. Exactly, do you know anything about it?” she asked the ruler of Armoria, and she grimaced in irritation.

„According to one of the guards who sent us the message, it was a dark-skinned woman with a scar on her face, so it was definitely Lonnie. What Alarm detected was definitely a diversion.” she said, clenching her fists.

„It wasn't a diversion, I'm sure of that.” she replied in a gloomy tone, remembering the creature she and Glimmer had seen. On the other hand, Lonnie gained new allies who gave her this strange organic Weapon. And then there was Dr. Moors, the memory of whom made her shudder. But this was unbelievable, she remembered the evil emanating from that being and she doubted even Lonnie would be willing to cooperate with something so terrible.

„Post guards on the outer part of the castle and have someone provide me with the most accurate and oldest plans of the castle possible.” she said, and for a few moments they discussed the next course of action. Eventually they talked about everything, almost everything.

„What about my father… Lord Admiral Antares.” she asked, feeling growing anxiety.

„He sent his guard away and went to talk to Lady Sorrowflame. The guards say that this woman, this Lady Sorrowflame, was... Ugh, she turned into something strange, like a dragon or something.” Juliette explained.

Her anxiety increased. First Adora, now her father. They were both in danger, far from any help, with such a terrible danger looming. And there was Shadow Weaver lurking out there somewhere, wasn't this all her doing? The last most terrible harm she could do to her? Did she want to take away the family she had just acquired? She felt like she was in a nightmare, completely powerless, helpless like a child. She couldn't become the same helpless creature she once was again. Melog, feeling a wave of fear wash over her, turned blue and folded her ears, wailing piteously.

„Juliette, Netossa, please take care of everyone, I have to look for them before... Before everything is lost. Tell me , where was the last time you saw my father?” She asked, trying to control the panic that was taking over her.

„The Lord Admiral was last seen heading towards the old Cemetery, but...„ Netossa began, but she didn't finish because she was interrupted.

„Okay, I'm going there. If you meet Adora, tell her where I went.„ she said and ran with Melog, not paying attention to the worried look that both commanders gave her, or to the black bird that flew after her cawing proudly.

It was too easy. Although she didn't expect this woman to be able to do magic, it didn't change much. And so they managed to kidnap her, mainly thanks to the staff she received from Mi-Go. Unlike Catra, the ruler of Eridani turned out to be susceptible to his power. Well, no matter what you say, her former friend had a stronger mind than any princess from outside Etheria, apparently they were much weaker than those from their planet. They did cause an explosion, which worried and saddened Kyle, but in the end, no one was actually hurt, so they did a lot better than they expected. One building, a distillery belonging to former Horde technicians, burned down, but if they want to go there for compensation, he will give it to them, we can afford it. The streets were empty, no one was stopping her because of the impending threat, they just had to get out of here. She felt a bit stupid leaving all these inhabitants without help, but hey, they had their princesses, Adora She-Ra and the rest. It was now up to them to keep them safe. She told Kyle and Rogelio this and they nodded grimly. Scarlet seemed scared, even the imp was glum, only Doctor Moors was happily jumping on the rooftops, he was much more mobile than he had previously said. Everything was going great, so why did she feel so miserable? Suddenly their communicator went off.

„It's me.” she heard Shadow Weaver's voice. “The Lord Admiral captured Itel. I'm going to save her, just like Eti and the rest. You can do whatever you want, but without them the ship probably won't take off. They are keeping her near the old cemetery” said the dark Sorceress and hung up.

„Fuck!” she shouted, stopping. Her friends looked at her. She briefly explained to them what Shadow Weaver had told her. After listening to her, Kyle nodded and said.

„Well, we're going to get her, right?” Rogelio, who was carrying the unconscious Empress, nodded. She looked at them in disbelief.

„You guys must be crazy! We have to get out of here as soon as possible!”

This time they looked at her in surprise.

„But Itel is one of us! We cannot leave it behind. After all, we promised each other that we would take care of each other... This also applies to the new and weak ones.” Kyle explained. He was actually right. They were no longer part of the Horde, where the individual did not count. They wanted to create something more. But the risk…

„I'm going anyway, regardless of what you decide.” Scarlet said in a confident tone.

„Okay, we'll do that. Me, Imp and Scarlet will go rescue Itel, and Kyle, Doctor Moors and Rogelio will carry the Empress to the ship. Let's see what Shadow Weaver comes up with.”

She knew something was going on here that she didn't quite understand. This girl attacked Catra's father, although they had no idea why she did it, at least she didn't hurt him. She left the child with Ashurk, who wanted to record a video with them anyway or something like that. She still didn't understand half of what the

insectoid woman was saying, but she suspected there must be something important hidden there. Since so many beings were watching her. Even though she thought it was all nonsense, she really didn't know much about social matters. Thanks to Ashurk's help, she had time to do what she had been planning for a long time, which was to talk to the Lord Admiral about his technology, but she had barely exchanged a few words with him when this explosion occurred and then this girl attacked. She came from outside Etheri and fought in a way unknown here, although it was of little use against the Lord Admiral, Catra's father was a truly great warrior. However, the girl was knocked down by Lady Ka using an Electric baton. She stiffened for a moment at the sight, as it brought back one of the worst memories of her life, when Catra had banished her to Beast Island. Using this weapon at full power was not only painful, but also deprived of control over one's own body. Lady Ka seemed to enjoy it, she didn't understand how terrible it felt? That's why she preferred to stay with her, she really didn't want to leave them alone, although she couldn't say why... After all, Catra's father was a good man who wouldn't let his captive get hurt, right?

The girl was tied up by some soldiers serving Lady Ka, they did not look as neat as the Lord Admiral's subordinates, although they seemed to be equally dangerous. One of them seemed interesting, it was a short individual similar to those living in Taurus, the planet liberated by Catra's father. She had never met any of them, though she was almost certain he was from outside the Empire, which made him interesting in itself. His name was Graag and he had a cybernetic prosthetic leg and some kind of implant in his skull. At first she wanted to ask him everything, but Bow once told her that she shouldn't start a conversation by asking about such things. She had heard that it would be a good idea to start by talking about more neutral topics. The weather was nice and there was nothing more to say about it... Others also liked talking about pets and children. She didn't have any pets, although she was thinking about building a mechanical dog for her child, but she had a child! She took out her Datapad and started showing Graag photos of her husband and child. Her

interlocutor turned strangely pale when he saw Hordak's photo. Well, the people of Etheria hadn't fully forgiven him for the whole Horde thing and all, and those coming from other regions of the Empire weren't very supportive of his relationship with the clones, but Graag had come from outside the Empire, along with the Lord Admiral's men! So why was he reacting so strangely?

The girl was then tied up and placed against a wall, and some sedative drugs were administered. When at one point Lady Ka went aside to talk to someone via the communicator that she had taken from the girl, she loosened her bonds and gave her a mild stimulant because someone else could have overdosed on them. Lady Ka definitely did not have the skills to care for the sick. During this time, she listened to what the Lord Admiral's deputy was saying. She had to admit that she didn't like it very much, although maybe she didn't know the context. She wasn't sure who this ugly girl was, maybe she was Lady Ka's friend. She heard that it was very common among friends to call each other offensive names, for example Catra was very fond of calling Adora an idiot, and was also fond of calling Glimmer Sparkles, it could be similar here... Lady Ka also mentioned her sister and her kitty. This was also puzzling... She remembered that Lady Ka was also a clone, which meant that her sister was also a clone. She was curious about the relationships between other clones. Horde Prime clones didn't always like each other, although it was the same with regular siblings... Then she had a strange thought that she could be talking about Catra's sister, but referring to someone adult and not your partner as pet is inadvisable... Even offensive

„And about this girl... what do you want to do with her? She is a captive, so you should take care of her properly... What do you do with captives?” she asked carefully. She felt like she had raised a very important issue.

„We usually keep them in prison camps, and sometimes we let them go free...„ the woman giggled, her sense of humor required deep analysis „ and what do you, ns of Etheria, do with prisoners of war? – she added after a while.

„ It depends... Glimmer’s Mother locked them in the spare bedroom, or at least that's what she did with Shadow Weaver, and in the Horde... „ she lowered her head again that day, remembering her exile.

„Spare bedroom? I guess your queen's mother missed her husband very much.” She giggled again in that strange, slightly irritating way. She was about to ask what she meant when an alarm was announced from the loudspeakers.

„Hey, Dad... I'll say it very simply, because I don't have time for stupid talk. Either you let her go, or I'll use one of your rock Incinerators and destroy this city.

„Fuck you!” Lady Ka screamed… Her way of speaking was really terrible!

„It's already done.” Eti said to Rosie in sign language. Breaking into the city's news network wasn't hard, even she could do it. They really didn't know anything about computer security here. That was it, now she just had to rely on others for help. The winter flame rekindled in her heart again, but this time it gave her strength. She saw everything clearly now, her thoughts were clearer than ever. She was strong and smart, she could do anything, absolutely anything. Part of her knew it was a sign of stormy days, but it could be useful to her. She wasn't afraid of anything now, and fear was now her worst enemy. If she submits to him, he may fail, and then Itel will die. She couldn't imagine what she would do then. Itel was her best friend, even if not her beloved... Apart from Bina and Mrs. Ka, she knew no one else so long. She was the first one she saw after she lost her arm. She was seriously considering blowing up this city.

„Follow me, Rosie!” she exclaimed, supporting herself on the roof with her wonderful shoes, her girlfriend jumped in after her.

He was worried about Lonnie and even Scarlet, but there was nothing he could do about it. The ComradeGeneral may have been his girlfriend, but she was also his commander, and he had to obey her orders, even if he didn't agree with them. Besides, he wasn't able to help her, not as Kyle, and he couldn't become the latter with Lonnie... Suddenly he felt overwhelming fear and looked towards the Horizon. A winged monster of evil and death hovered over the city , following Brightmoon towards the screams and sounds of battle. He sensed a different evil from there, dark and unnatural. His sword pulsated with power. He couldn't help Lonnie, but maybe he could help the others.

„Rogelio... I have to do something myself. Please don't stop me.” he said to his boyfriend. Rogelio nodded hesitantly and moved towards the ship, while he went into a side street, drew his sword and shouted.

„I have the Power!”

She ran tirelessly on all four limbs, never slowing down, and Melog ran right next to her, emanating the colors of all the feelings that burned in her heart. She had to make sure her father was safe. She was also afraid for Adora, she really wanted to be separated, but if she had to choose... Adora was able to cope with the group of kidnappers, but her father was only a human, she knew well how easy it was to hurt and kill an ordinary person. If Shadow Weaver was here, if she allied with that monster to get her father...

Suddenly, out of the corner of her eye, she saw a figure, the shadow of the person she knew so well, who had put so much effort into turning her life into a nightmare. The one who manipulated her and Adora to achieve her goals, caring about their feelings and desires, and now wanted to do the same to her sister. The one she hated with all her heart. But she soon lost sight of her, and she would have believed that she was just imagining it, but she had a feeling... The same strange tingling

she had felt all these years in Shadow Weaver's presence. Everyone who lived in the Fright Zone, especially every cadet, developed this skill if they did not want to suffer. Melog turned purple due to the anxiety and anger she felt. She hesitated for a moment, and then she heard a voice coming from the speakers. She was sure it was her sister's voice, she remembered it well. She didn't understand whose release she was talking about, but she was sure that the girl was ready to carry out her threat… She was so much like her after all…. Shadow Weaver definitely knew where her sister was. She made her decision.

She failed again, she was arguing with that stupid girl and didn't notice Lonnie was there. She just wanted to follow Adora's order, but she was too focused on him and now she had to save the situation. She had no idea what Catra's sister the girl was talking about, Catra definitely didn't have a sister! Unless you counted Adora or the other cadets, but then it started to get weird... As soon as she could, she left them in Swiftwind's care, he should deal with them, and she raced off on Shogi to find... Anyone. Fortunately, she encountered Mermista who was walking through the emptying streets. She was about to explain everything when there was an explosion. Mermista jumped.

„If Seahawk and Bow came up with this brilliant idea, Glimmer and I will kill them both.” the Sea Lady growled.

„No, it was Lonnie! She wants to kidnap the empress!” she exclaimed excitedly.\

„That Lonnie from the People's Rebellion... Catra and Adora's old friend? Wonderfully!” Mermista exclaimed.

„And there's still a Shadow Weaver around here somewhere... She survived somehow!” she started to tell her friend, who groaned with a tired voice.

„The scary old woman just discovered a way to get even scarier! This wedding just keeps getting more and more amazing! And I thought being late for your wedding was the worst thing that could happen at a wedding!” The woman brushed her dress nervously and said.

„I'll be running next to the shadows, so don't ride that thing too fast!” she looked at Shogi suspiciously, but then she patted her magical friend and he suddenly lengthened and grew to make room for Mermista.

„This is really strange, but since there is room... Just don't rush too fast, because I have to somehow stay on his back. – said the ruler of Salinea, mounting Shogi.

„Shogi will help you. – she said, and long tentacles wrapped around Mermista's legs and then moved forward!

She wasn't sure if Eti's message was a good idea, but it would definitely give Catra something to think about, and maybe she'd start to wonder who her father was. She had no idea how true the scout's threat was, but if she and Catra were so similar... Catra, if she was cornered, wouldn't hesitate to use such a terrible weapon, at least on her bad days, it was enough to remember the story with the portal, and Eti was even more unpredictable... she could only hope that the worst wouldn't happen... Wrongdak ran next to her with a fierce expression on his face. Despite all the differences that existed between them, the clone had grown attached to these kids. He was probably able to outrun her effortlessly, after all, he was in much better shape than either her or his brother. Knowing Hordak, it was easy to forget what his kind was created for... She was breathing heavily. She had never been very physically fit, especially compared to her sisters, and all the decades that had passed since she left her home islands had only worsened her health. Maybe instead of spending all these years drinking and feeling sorry for herself, she took up physical exercises and she wouldn't be coughing up her lungs now... But

this is not the time to curse about what you didn't do, she had to cope.

She found herself close to the cemetery, still sensing the battle going on in the distance. She couldn't separate the powers that were fighting there, but she knew they were great powers, and she doubted she could handle any of them, despite all the power she was given. She couldn't let such things distract her anyway, she had to focus on her goal. He was so close, she could already see Lady Ka standing by the roaring fountain surrounded by her subordinates, a Duergar, the Gnol, Shirren and a few thugs of a species that was difficult to determine. The girl was sitting against the wall, tied up and not very conscious. Entrapta was standing next to her, was she involved in the conspiracy? No... She might not have known her very well, but she certainly wasn't someone who would conspire with someone like Mrs. Ka. She unleashed so many shadows, the darkness began to swirl around her, weaving a spell...

„Good night Ka, it's good that we can finally see each other with our own eyes... although in your case it will be more through the eye."

Lady Ka bit her lip in anger. At first, that purple-haired idiot didn't want to leave. The Admiral had given her a glare to forbid any harm to her, so no great accident could happen to her, she was great at inventing terrible accidents, and on top of that, she couldn't break that fucking elf's legs, and then that scarred bitch started threatening her. Who was she to threaten her? A stupid witch from a dirty planet who couldn't even discipline her pet. And then her little kitten started threatening her. Her! The one who owned her and she was her property, which she only sold to her new master. And on top of that, she threatened her with the weapon she had so perfidiously stolen from the Lord Admiral. So when she saw the damn Witch mention her eyes in her fucking ignorance, she giggled and said with gleeful hatred.

„You know what? Fuck of!” and pointed the gun at the girl and shot. The purple-haired idiot screamed.

Chapter End Notes

Good cliffhanger is not bad. Please leave your comments and feedback.

Calamity

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She had to admit that riding Frosta 's strange creature was extremely comfortable, though not as comfortable as Sea Flash, her undersea mount. The problem was that they didn't know how to find the kidnappers... and anyone else anyone. However, Frosta seemed to have a plan... She seemed to be fighting with herself until she finally spoke to her friend.

„Shogi , do you remember Nightgale ... That woman we saw in the underground...„

Her strange creature barked happily, but she asked.

„Who is Nightgale? I've never heard about her.”

Frosta thought for a moment about what to say…. Until she finally explained.

„I thought she was a friend...„ her voice was full of bitterness...

Aaravos hovered next to her, clearly amused. He irritated her. But she couldn't even answer him in any way, which only enraged her even more.

„What a great example of heroism! The inhabitants of this planet are incredibly brave and stupid at the same time. From the point of view of natural selection, this is truly absurd... or not... After all, sacrificing individuals to save the entire population is one of the basic survival strategies of all species. I heard that this one of them... That She-Ra, has a great tendency to make sacrifices.

This is probably one of the basic elements of her identity. Well, she might have to make some sacrifices to beat what's coming, although that would be a poor trade-off in my opinion. The little brother will eat at most a hundred people, maybe a bit more, but She-Ra is priceless, especially considering our plans.” explained the star Saihe in the tone of a scholar, lying in the air with his hands behind his head. She shot him an angry look that almost caused her to trip. Aaravos smiled at her and added.

„You probably really regret that you can't answer me, but believe me, I regret it very much too. The only person I can communicate with is Claudia. A very talented girl, but with a very simple personality. It's hard to have intelligent conversations with her like it is with you or your mother. Perhaps you will meet someday. You would like her, you would get along well, although unfortunately she has had a boyfriend for some time, but it is not a problem that you could not solve.” he laughed briefly.

„Shut up!” she drawled shortly.

„Who are you talking to?” Lonnie looked at her angrily, and unfortunately she couldn't explain what she was doing. In moments like these, she sincerely regretted performing the ritual and contacting the star Saihe . He knew way too much about her and she knew next to nothing about him. This was obviously dangerous.

The city was completely deserted and no one was stopping them. They heard an announcement from Eti. Lonnie called it a bluff, but she wasn't so sure. She had heard about their family... She had also heard about what Catra had done when she was furious, although at that time her consciousness was just waking up and she remembered almost nothing from that period... But she understood the scout. She was willing to do almost anything for Scarlet...

They ran in from the alley and she saw her mother, shrouded in darkness, slowly and majestically walking towards a group of several people who looked like bandits, led by Lady Ka. She saw

Itel and Entrapta near the wall , she had no idea where the inventor came from, but it could have ended very badly for her.

Then, out of the corner of her eye, she saw two women and a goat-like creature running towards her in a side street. One of them was Frosta, and the other unknown person was probably Mermista, she know how sea princess look like. This was something she hadn't expected at all, the two elemental princesses were a difficult enemy, but she was truly afraid of Shogot . She didn't know how much Frosta controlled him, but she didn't want to be devoured by the ancient monster. So when she saw that the ruler of Salinea was trying to throw a stream of water at her, she felt the spell on her, hoping that the Sea Princess would attack Shogoth ...

But then she heard a gunshot and Frosta ended up towards them…

Frosta's plan worked, although she still had the feeling that she hadn't told her everything, but they could talk about it later. Now they saw their target, two women, one of whom she had met a few times before, so she knew her name was Lonnie, but she didn't recognize the redhead. Then she will ask her name. She had already learned the value of having a waterskin with her, so she was never defenseless. However, she could now use water from the Brightmoon sewage system; during the war, she discovered that the sewage system in every city was equally dirty. Now, however, it needed a lot of water power… strange sentence…

However, when she summoned water, the red-haired woman noticed her and cast some kind of spell on her. She suddenly felt strange, as if something very bad was coming for her. She remembered how she was chipped , and now it was similar... She was again surrounded by enemies with the faces of friends who wanted to take away her freedom and power over her own body and mind. He won't let this happen again!

She saw movement next to her… one of them approached her from behind. She looked like Frosta, but she wasn't Frosta, not anymore, just someone who had stolen her body and now wanted to do the same to her! She had to defend herself! She wrapped water around the creature and threw it as far as she could. As the creature with Frosta's face was grabbed by her water, it looked towards her with surprise evident on its stolen features. She didn't expect that her trick would be discovered, but she would not allow herself to be enslaved... Never more

Itel was already feeling better. The pain in his shoulder was gone, except for the burning sensation in the burned area. The sedatives were wearing off, thanks in part to the help of that strange purple-haired woman, was she Wrongdak's old friend? She also loosened her bonds. She did n't understand why she did it, she had previously treated the Lord Admiral in a friendly manner, apparently she didn't know the truth about this man, like everyone else... She didn't show that she was conscious, that was her only advantage. Now she realized how stupid she had been by attacking Antares . She was no match for him. Now she was in captivity of Lady Ka. At first she wanted to act brave and pretend that she didn't want her friends to save her, but one look at the smiling Lady Ka made her silently pray to all the gods for someone to save her. She was aware that nothing would be done to her just because of the purple-haired woman's presence, otherwise she would have screamed in pain. A little comfort entered her heart when she heard Eti's threat, even though it enraged Lady Ka. However, she was afraid that Eti would ultimately fulfill her threat, bringing death to all of them. Still, despite all the anger hidden in her heart, she didn't want Eti to do this.

Rescue came from an unexpected direction. She saw a shadow moving towards them, a swirling darkness emanating Terror. She once treated Shadow Weaver with contempt, seeing her as nothing more than an old, bitter woman. This didn't change either after they saved Eti thanks to her or after she learned her true identity. However, seeing is believing. Now she finally understood

who the Dark Sorcerer was. And she shuddered. Surprisingly, Lady Ka wasn't bothered by the sight of the Mistress of Shadows, although perhaps that shouldn't have surprised her since she knew Etii. When she saw the woman raise the gun, she freed her hands from the restraints and jumped. She felt pain in her arm and Entrapta screamed horribly

Frosta was surprised that Mermista was throwing her with her water jets. She saw fear and anger in her friend's eyes. She had no idea what had happened to her, perhaps it was the spell cast by Nightgale. *What had she done to he*r she thought as she rolled along the way. The landing was quite successful, fortunately she was athletic and had often practiced safe falls from the backs of mountain chamois and oxen . As she was getting up she heard a gunshot so she jumped to her feet and looked around. On one side was a scared Entrapta and a woman who worked for Catra's dad, she think her name was Lady Ka, along with a few thug-looking subordinates, and some Saihe girl holding her arm, but on the other side, was Her… She didn't see Shadow Weaver very often, and she never spoke to her. She also never saw her use magic. Now she saw a dark sorceress shrouded in shadows, preparing to cast a spell. She remembered that it was because of Entrapta that she once lost her position... She definitely wanted to put some dark curse on her! Without thinking, she jumped ahead.

She was arrogant again. Once again she was carried away by the feeling of power, of might pulsing through her veins. She thought that such a display would scare Lady Ka, who would leave the captured elf, but the woman showed her with one swipe of her finger how much the power of sorcery meant to her. In a sense, she understood her, she herself would have done the same. After all, the best way to deal with threats is to show others how little they mean to you... Yes. Eti was right. Lady Ka looked so much like her... In fact, she was now looking into a mirror, and it wasn't even crooked, just a little dirty. Yes, she looked at herself and the

sight was… cathartic… Few have ever had the chance to look at themselves and understand who they really are… And also to annihilate themselves. Yes! She finally understood! This woman was to Eti what she was to Catra. If she kills her, he may also kill a part of himself that she hated so much . Perhaps then Eti will decide that she is not so bad after all. That she deserved forgiveness... She began to weave a spell... She spent those years on Carurystal not only drinking, she also learned a few things. Lady Ka was too absorbed by Itel to notice her casting the spell... When she finished the incantation, she threw dark power at the woman, but a girl stood in the path of the projectile of dark power. Was it Frosta? She wasn't sure, but she didn't have time to think about it because someone jumped on her back, pressing her to the ground. She felt the touch of sharp claws on her neck.

„If you move, I'll rip your throat out. "Catra said in a voice that echoed with years of true hatred. And then a hail of plasma bolts fell on the battlefield.

Eti jumped onto the roof and lay down on its edge and started aiming. Didn't Lady Ka remember that she was a shooter? Jantar made her this way on her father's orders, to be as murderous as her mother... No... She was supposed to be much more terrible... She was created from a line of two murderers, one worse than the other. But now she was grateful for the skills she had been given… they would now be necessary for her to save Itel. Rosie stood behind her, looking around warily. She was supposed to insure her in case Lady Ka turned out to be smarter than she seemed.

When she saw it through the Scope of the Sniper Rifle, the cold firestorm in her heart erupted into a conflagration. One movement of a finger was enough to destroy the head of the one who tormented her, who had mutilated her hand and who had left so many scars on her soul. It was with the greatest effort of will that

she stopped herself from shooting the woman. She had to control herself, otherwise Itel would die...

Then Shadow Weaver came looking like she was a living darkness. She was grateful for this, because she suspected that the dark sorceress was risking a lot by drawing attention to herself with this show of power.

But then Lady Ka shot Itel.

„NO!” she screamed and shot at Lady Ka, but at the same time the woman in the half-mask dodged because Shadow Weaver threw a dark spell at her. The clone woman was covered anyway by a short girl dressed in blue, who fell to the ground, struck by dark magic. She ignored her because she had to find Itel. Fortunately, the Elf was alive and free, although she was wounded in the arm, but she summoned her solarian blade. However, Lady Ka's soldiers started shooting at the fleeing girl. Itel was dodging, but one of the bullets was about to hit her. So she did what was necessary. First, she aimed at the Gnol armed with a laser rifle, aiming straight at his chest. She squeezed the trigger and a ball of burning plasma hit Lady Ka's henchman's chest, burning a smoking hole in it. Then she aimed it at an Elf and fired again, as she had been trained to do, between heartbeats. He was dead, another dead body, another life taken by her. She couldn't think about it. She had to fight and perhaps continue to kill, after all, she was a murderer. Then she took aim at another enemy, but when she aimed at the next one, Shirren in the brown trench coat, he looked at her and started shooting, so she had to jump away and lie on the roof. She heard numerous screams, many of them she recognized, one even seemed to belong to her sister, who was threatening to rip someone's throat out. Lonnie and Scarlet were here too, as well as Wrongdak. However, she heard shouts from the nearby rooftops, but Mrs. ka was not stupid at all. She looked around her. Four soldiers ran towards them. These were Lady Ka's Goons, armed with Horde electric batons and assault shields, and they wanted to take her alive. Let them try! She grabbed her Rifle and shot the first one several times. He dodged most of the shots except the last one, which hit him in the

leg. He was yelling, but she didn't think he should complain. He was alive, and that couldn't be said of many of his companions. The two charged at Rosie, but she was already glowing. She hit the first one's shield, shattering it, then punched him in the jaw, cracking it until he spit out his teeth. She knocked the second one off the roof with a roundhouse kick. She was so beautiful when she broke other people's bones. She knocked the last one down with a few blows from the butt of her rifle. They didn't have time to rejoice in their victory, because the drone started shooting at them with an electric cannon and also fired several gas grenades. This was a bigger problem. She had a mask and goggles, but Rosie was unprotected. She pointed at the drone with her metal hand, and an energy bolt was fired from it, knocking the machine down.

„I didn't know I could do that.” she muttered under her breath, but then a rainbow light flashed nearby and Rosie's eyes started to glow and the white”haired girl, her girlfriend, ran in that direction.

„NO!„ Nightgale screamed as she saw Frosta trying to shield Lady Ka from the spell cast by her mother. The girl fell to the ground and appeared to be dead. At this time, Eti started firing from the roof. She killed three soldiers, but missed Lady Ka.

„Cast the Spell!” Lonnie ordered her and he jumped into battle. A short armored warrior stood in front of Lonnie. She had heard of these beings, he was a dwarf or duergar, she didn't fully understand the differences between these beings. The warrior wielded a hammer, with electric sparks flying across its surface. He took the first blow on his armor and laughed loudly.

„Are you guys making fucking staves out of Adamant? But this planet is fucked up.” he said, striking a sweeping blow with his weapon. Lonnie retreated under this violent attack. Meanwhile, she cast another spell on two thugs trying to get at Lonnie from behind. A wave of rainbow light shot out from her fingers,

shocking the two attackers, causing them to fall to the ground, deafened and blinded. She started to weave another spell when the strange insectoid in the trench coat started shooting at her. One of his bullets grazed her cheek and she felt terribly cold. She cursed and hid behind the fountain, luckily the spell she was casting didn't require her to see the target. She summoned several balls of magical Energy that flew towards the shooter. However, they did not knock him down, but only wounded him. At this time, Lonnie teleported from behind Duergar, but he quickly turned around trying to avoid the blow. He took the blow on his shoulder and winced painfully as his armor cracked, but he raised his hammer with one hand and struck it mightily against the ground. A powerful wave of electricity spread in all directions and shocked the General's Companion. She tried to weave another spell, but she had to hide from the fire. The duergar rose and swung to strike the blow that would kill Lonnie. Then she saw Wrongdak running towards the dwarf himself, holding something like an Ax or a Pickaxe in his hand.

„Do you remember me...„ the clone said in an angry voice.

The hammer warrior looked at him in surprise, then laughed hoarsely.

„It's you! Eh, I could have crushed your paws, but maybe now it will work... „ and he took a deep swing, but the clone was the first, with a powerful blow he drove the tip of the weapon into the other arm of the Duergar, who screamed in pain and fell to his knees, dropping the weapon from his hand. The dwarf gritted his teeth angrily and glared with pure hatred at the clone, who seemed unfazed.

„I swear that you and your kind will pay me back!” the Duergar shouted , but they didn't pay much attention to him because the fight was still going on. Lonnie got to her feet. She swayed slightly, but blocked Lady Ka's electric baton strike, then with a deft punch she tripped the Lord Admiral's second-in-command, and then Nightgale cast a magic dust spell that blinded most of the enemies, then offered Lady Ka's arm, and both women fled.

And then they saw a flash of rainbow light nearby... and few minutes later the entire city went dark.

She was a murderer, she killed Light Hope. The AI wasn't evil, its compatriots made it that way. Surely there was a way to save her, even if not when the Heart was activated, then before. If she hadn't been so afraid, if she had dared to take a risk... If she had asked the right questions, instead of believing everything she was told... She had freed herself from the Shadow Weaver's clutches, but she had left Catra there , just as she had freed herself from the cursed legacy of her people but sacrificed Light Hope. She couldn't take back what she had done. She had to save Catra now , nothing bad could happen to her. She couldn't fail her like she had failed Light Hope.

She and the Lady of Blades found themselves in someone's garden. Catra was nowhere to be found, apparently the teleportation didn't work as it should. Well, she didn't take much of it. Someday she needs to practice teleporting herself even though the voices were constantly talking to her. The Lady of Blades took a deep breath and then spoke.

„It was... an extraordinary experience. I have to leave you... I'll look for Lady Cala, I have a score to settle with her... You look for your wife. " said the knight and ran towards the castle. Meanwhile, she heard the sounds of fighting. With a trembling heart, she ran in that direction.

Catra in a side street overlooking a fountain across from the cemetery. Her beloved was pressing a woman to the ground. The cat girl's face was furious. At first she didn't understand what was happening, but then she looked at the woman and saw her scared face and then gasped.

"Shadow Weaver," she whispered, and then Catra looked at her, seeing fear, anger, and despair in her eyes.

„I was so afraid she did something to you. To you or to my father... „ she said, her voice breaking. Tears were streaming down her face.

„You should listen.” Shadow Weaver tried to say, but Catra hit her hard on the head, knocking the dark sorceress unconscious.

„Be silent!„ Her wife shouted. Melog stood off to the side, sparkling with many colors. He looked no less confused than his companion. Catra stood up, swaying on her feet. She wanted to ask her what happened. And hold them in their arms and cry, but then someone landed next to them. When she turned around, she was surprised to see Rosie. She smiled, because it meant that Catra's sister might be nearby ... But there was something strange about Rosie. The girl emanated a white glow, her eyes were covered with what looked like white matter. Her fists were clenched… Then all the lights in the city went out and the white-haired girl shone like a lantern in the darkness.

„Rosie?” she asked the girl carefully. Something was very wrong here. Rosie looked at her and jumped towards her. The girl moved with incredible speed. It hit her in the chest with such force that she fell back several meters, and the power inside her wavered. She lost her breath and a voice rang in her head.

„YOU FAILED!!”

She stood up as quickly as she could. The girl hit her with her fist again and again. She blocked each blow with her shield, feeling her power wavering after each powerful blow, like a flame in the wind. She drew more power. Meanwhile, Catra jand Melogumped on Rosie's back, but the white-haired girl threw her against the wall with one wave of her hand.

„Catra!– she shouted and attacked the girl, turning the shield into a stick. Her blows were lightning fast, but Rosie dodged them effortlessly. Then the girl grabbed her stick with one hand and struck her in the chest with the other, knocking her out of her knees.

„YOU BETRAYED!” the voice rang in her heart once again. The girl grabbed her by the throat and lifted her up. She felt something draining her power. She returned to her true form.

„THE SENTENCE IS DEATH!” screamed a voice in her head. The girl tightened her hand around her neck, but then another figure jumped down from the nearby wall. She looked so much like Catra... She put her hand on the girl's shoulder and said.

„It's okay, Rosie... Nothing happened. Everything's all right.” Eti said in a very tired voice and light flowed out of Rosie. The girl blinked several times and when she looked at her, horror appeared in her eyes. She released her, and then she and Eti ran into the darkness. She felt exhausted, but steeled herself and walked over to Catra, who was getting up.

„Everything hurts, I think she broke some bone, but I don't know what.” her wife laughed, and then grimaced painfully. Then they heard footsteps and Lady Ka entered their Alley.

„I see that the brides are whole and healthy... It's worse with this short one... How she was named? Frosta?” she said and put the Horde's electric baton at Shadow Weaver, who was trying to get up...

Calamity was very pleased with herself. Not only did she punish the wicked thief and play a prank on Shadow Weaver, she also gained a lot of valuable information. And all this with almost no planning. Apparently, despite what Shadow Weaver said, improvisation is the key to success. Now she just had to think about how the acquired knowledge could benefit her cause. One thing was certain, he had to contact that Elven Warlock that was floating near Nightgale ... The drawings referred to someone like him, a wizard with so much power that Shadow Weaver was compared him like a clumsy schoolgirl. This could be a fascinating discovery... One that will help her regain the destiny she was so

treacherously deprived of. And then the whole universe will tremble with horror and delight.

When she got outside, through one of the hidden passages at the bottom of the cliff where the castle was located, she saw that the city was shrouded in darkness. But has this creature breached the princesses' defense? That would have made this day even more wonderful, but unfortunately when she got to the city, she saw no signs of mass murder anywhere... Life had always brought her disappointments... She knew she should take the opportunity to run away, but she couldn't resist the temptation to tell the feline creature that she is a widow. This will be the most wonderful moment of her life.

Suddenly, a figure jumped out of the alley and punched her in the face with a metal fist as hard as she could. She fell to the ground and looked up. She saw Dilayla and Arkan”tar standing over her , as well as Star Siblings.

„Surprised to see me alive?” Dilayla asked, smiling and pointing her rifle at her.

Yes, life always brought her disappointments.

Asindesa di Vir ran as fast as she could, but she was still late. As she stood outside the castle walls, she saw Dilayla, Arkan-tar and others leading Lady Cala at gunpoint. The aristocrat seemed amused, but as soon as she saw her, she suddenly become sad, obviously seeing her alive not what she expected. The Queen was already standing at the gate, together with Scorpia and Perfuma. After a moment, Adora and Catra joined them. The cat girl was leaning on the shoulder of her wife, who had already returned to her natural form.

„Adora, Catra, are you okay?” Glimmer asked the queen with concern in her voice.

„Nothing serious although she tried to make it seem otherwise.” the princess of power looked at Lady Cala, who had just been brought before the queen.

„What's that supposed to mean?” Glimmer asked in a sharp tone

Lady Cala lowered her head and said, her voice breaking.

„ I didn't want to... she forced me to do it... Shadow Weaver... She used her magic and...

Catra interrupted her.

„We have her here too...„ she said in a sharp tone. The Hell Knight felt her heart beat faster. She was here, the woman she loved so much, and who had betrayed her… Now Lady Cala was going to put all the blame for her misdeeds on her. However, she saw the joy in her eyes as she crippled Adora's soul. She won't let this wicked girl get away with her punishment. Her back was turned to her, no one was paying the slightest attention to the Lady of Blades... She grabbed her sword and with a shout she jumped forward, pierced the blade through Lady Cala's back, spun it around, then pulled it out and stabbed it in front of her. She knelt down and closed her eyes, waiting for what Fate would bring... And then laughter resounded...

Glimmer watched with a mixture of surprise and horror as Lady Cala, whose chest had been pierced by a Hellknight's blade before her own eyes, began to laugh. Her blood, which had recently stained the white stones, turned purple.

„Apparently this blade was not created to hurt people like me... Unfortunately, in this way I was forced to reveal my true identity. But maybe it's better this way? It's time to end this pathetic masquerade.„ Cala said when she stopped laughing. Her voice was as gentle as ever, although there was a hint of mockery in it. The girl stood up and then everyone let out an exclamation of astonishment as the previously fatal wound healed before their

eyes. Lady Cala soon looked completely healthy, only stains on her dress and a tear where the sword had pierced suggested that the woman had been injured.

„Please, noble queen, let me finally introduce myself to you by my real name. I AM CALAMITY!” she said and bowed humbly. Then she started to transform. She became taller, bone claws emerging from the fingers of her right hand and a bone blade emerging from her left forearm. When she stood up, she found that her facial features had become sharper, and one eye had turned completely purple, as if the pupil had changed color and spread over the entire eye.

„I'm beautiful, aren't I?” she said and laughed loudly.

„Who... What are you?” Juliette asked, sword in hand. Her daughter stood next to her with her head down. What she saw must have been a shock for the girl. After all, Klementine had feelings for Lady Cala.

„I AM THE CHILD OF THE ONE WHO IS ALWAYS OR EVERYWHERE. THE ONE WHO KNOWS AND SEES EVERYTHING. I AM SPAWN OF GREAT OUTER GOD YOG-SOTOTH!” she said in a strangely resonant voice that rang in her ears. She took a step forward with each word. She saw that the woman was approaching Spinnerella with her children, Scorpia with Perfuma , and the Bowa brothers with their families.

”I AM PERFECTION INCARNATED!” she exclaimed, and then long tentacles with long spikes at the ends sprouted from her back. She slammed them towards Spinnerella's children, but she was faster. She teleported near Lady Cala and grabbed her forearm, and then they both moved again. She took the woman to the basement of Brightmoon , to a cell that had been built several years ago on her orders, in case of just such situations. It was completely identical to the one Horde Prime held her in. She wasn't proud of this project, but now it was extremely useful. Lady Cali's tentacles hit the wall and she teleported behind the force field. Lady Cala looked around, and when she realized where

she was, she roared and began punching the force field with all her might, but she was unable to break it. Horde Prime took great care to ensure that his prisoners could not escape. She knew something about it...

Chapter End Notes

Isn't Lady Cala beautiful? What do you think about this chapter?

Musical motifs of the characters from The Princess of Nothingness

Eterna "Eti" - Perfect
Rosie Pearl - King of My Castle.
Lady Cala/Calamity - We Are Devils.
Lord Admiral Felix Antares - Empire.
Heart Gift - Sound of Silence
Lady Sorrowflame - Smaug Song
Itel - Enemy
Doctor Sidonius and Jantar - Father
Captain Moonshadow - With Soldiers Eyes

Landscape after the battle

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Itel ran, stumbling. Her wound hurt with every step she took, but she knew she couldn't stop. She had to run from the enemy again without looking back. Although this time she wasn't alone. Running next to her were Scarlet and Lonnie, and Wrongdak and that woman with the prehensile purple hair. Comrade General was also tripping, that discharge must have seriously injured her. Wrongdak helped her, holding her arm. Luckily, he was so strong that she couldn't lean on it. The two of them led the others, because they were the only ones who could see in the night illuminated by the stars and moons. Soon she saw one figure running down from a nearby building, followed by another. She breathed a sigh of relief, Rosie and Eti were okay, although the cat girl looked glum and the deaf former intern seemed scared. But the most important thing was that they were together.

Soon they heard the sound of an approaching spaceship. For a moment she wondered if she should hide, lest it belong to the Lord Admiral, but soon she recognized the familiar silhouette of the Deadly Sword of Burning Fury... They were almost safe. The ship hovered above them and the side doors opened. Bina, Lilka and Rogelio stood there. A rope ladder was lowered.

„Get in, quickly! This blackout won't last long, and we need to get as close as possible before light returns.” Bina exclaimed. Everyone obeyed her, though Lonnie watched their captain warily. They entered one by one, but Wrongdak and his friend had to help her. Once she got to the top, ilka looked around and asked.

„Where's Miss Daisy?” she could hear concern in the redhead's voice.

„Catra got her.„ Eti said and looked through the side Door... „ I guess we should save her.” she added. Her voice was tired, even exhausted , but she slowly started to get up. She and Rosie did the same.

„Don't you dare! You won't risk it for this Hag.” Bina growled.

„She tried to save me... That's why she was captured.” she said, looking into her captain's eyes, but she only snorted.

„She definitely had some interest doing that, and as far as I know this planet, she's not in any danger... „ she added, smiling wryly.

„I'm going rescue her.” said Scarlet. “I can be Nighgale for a while. She shouldn't arouse suspicion... „ the sorceress looked at Lonnie, and she nodded hesitantly. Bina shrugged.

„You are neither my ward nor my friend, you can do whatever you want.”

Scarlet walked up to the Door and the ship slowed down and the scarlet haired woman climbed down the ladder. Then Bina looked at her and said sharply when she saw her wound.

„ March to Infirmary, Wrongdak, do you have medical training? – she asked, looking at the clone, who slowly nodded.

„Horde Prime taught us how to provide first aid and perform simple procedures. – he said carefully.

The purple-haired woman who had been looking around the ship in fascination suddenly called out.

„Can I go with Wrongdak? I am very curious about medical technologies!„ You could hear pure delight in her voice.

„„I guess yeah, but who are you anyway?” Bina asked.

“I am Entrapta... Your ship is very beautiful. I'd like to examine it. I thought I'd do this with the Lord Admiral's ships, but now that

I'm here... Does your ship have its own AI? Maybe he could be friends with Darla. This is my ship. Darla is a real lady, educated and with impeccable manners.” asked the purple-haired woman with hope in her voice.

„Unfortunately, I have to disappoint you. I'm just a biological organism cybernetically connected to this ship.„ said Mr. Ilemshaw, pointing one of his cameras towards Entrapta. “However, I do not rule out the possibility of making friends with this Darla, because I have no prejudices against Artificial Intelligence…”

„Oh, I must admit that you speak very nicely.” Entrapta replied.

„For now, stop matchmaking spaceships, and instead tell me how you came to be on my ship, and if you say you just got on it, my veins will burst.” Said vina

„Shouldn't you get a biological scan done? Internal bleeding can be dangerous... Especially in the central nervous system.” the purple-haired woman said with concern in her voice.

„I feel like I'm talking to another Eti, only less grumpy. Is she with you?” Bina asked, rubbing her temples, looking at Lonnie and her companions, but the General shook her head.

„She came with me... She had talked to the Lord Admiral earlier, but while Lady Ka was watching over me, she loosened my bonds and gave me a stimulant. Without it, I'd be dead.” Itel interjected

Bina looked at Entrapta a little more favorably, then looked around her ship. Her eyes fell on two tied people lying against the wall. One of them was a short human woman or a very tall Gnome, she wasn't entirely sure what she was, with wings growing out of her back. She stared blankly ahead with a blank smile on her face. The second was a short and petite girl in a suit that looked bionic. Bina's eyes widened in surprise when she saw her.

„Tirin? And where did you get it here? – she asked, not hiding her surprise.

„Normally. When we wanted to rob the museum, this girl ran into Rosie, so she knocked her out and we took her to the ship. – Eti replied, looking at Ka4pitan with an expression as if she had asked a very stupid question.

„And why did you drag her here to our ship? And what did you want to steal in this museum, because don't tell me that you wanted to see paintings and clay pots!„ Bina crossed her arms on her chest. Eti looked at her resentfully.

„You could think better of us. Perhaps our time here rekindled our love for Etherian folk art?" the cat-girl said, as if she was seriously offended.

„Eti…„ their captain said with a threat in her voice.

„Okay, we were supposed to steal Adora's old and broken sword for Lonnie, but we couldn't do it. Because Captain Wingy was there with a few other pirates, so we grabbed Tirin because she happened to be on our way..."

This time it was Lonnie who stood up and started shouting at them.

„Why the hell did you kidnap a random girl instead of the sword I told you to steal?"

„Because there were pirates there, and besides, I'm not going to rob the rightful ruler of Etheria. We will exchange the girl for a sword, because she is her replacement for her mean daughter, and everyone will be happy.„ said Eti.

Lonnie wanted to say something, but Bina wouldn't let her.

„First of all, miss, don't you dare yell at my kids on our ship, and second of all, what the hell is that other woman doing on this ship?" Bina was blushing with anger.

„This is Empress Eridani. We kidnapped her to force Glimmer to negotiate and listen to our demands." said Comrade General,

looking defiantly at Bina, who, however, didn't care much about it.

„You've probably gone completely crazy. You have just put yourself, most importantly, us, in conflict with a foreign country that will now be your sworn enemy. Congratulations on your diplomatic skills... Have you brought anyone else to our ship?" the Captain said in a sharp tone, until even Comrade General lost her composure in the confrontation with the burgundy-haired woman, and then Swifwind came out of the living compartment and said in an embarrassed voice.

„I think I messed up a bit, but in my defense I don't know how to use humanoid toilets."

„So we also have a talking horse?" Bina said in disbelief.

„It's not a horse, it's Mr. Swiftwind, he really doesn't like being called a horse... I'm coming, Mr. Swiftwind!" Lilka called and ran after Aricorn. Then Itel started laughing. She didn't know why and she didn't have the slightest control over it. She began to feel dizzy and fell to her knees. Before she lost consciousness, she heard.

„If you amputate her hand, will I be able to examine her prosthetic arm?"

'That was a disaster,' Glimmer thought, rubbing her temples. She was in the Council Room, it was already light outside the windows. She felt exhausted, more than ever before. She was active more than 24 hours a day, and sometimes even longer, especially at the end of the war, when they were preparing for the final battle against Horde Prime. It was different now. It was supposed to be the most beautiful day of her life. And in the lives of Bow, Adora and Catra. This was supposed to be the day when all of Etheria would celebrate the victory they had worked so hard to win. Everyone was supposed to rejoice and expect better days to come... But it turned out that darkness had come.

She never imagined that creatures like the monster they were fighting could exist. She had heard Catra's warnings about what she had seen in the depths of Mystacor and the ruins of that lost city, and her father's musings about the being summoned by the Shadow Weaver, but she didn't realize what they truly meant. This creature had no right to exist in this world. They were evil but not like Horde Prime. It was a predatory, primal evil. This monster wanted to devour them, and not just their bodies, but something more, their essence. They almost lost Scorpia and Perfuma. And there was nothing she could do to save them. She was absolutely defenseless against such a creature. If it hadn't been for this strange person coming to their rescue... They had no idea who he was or where he came from, but they were all grateful to him... If it weren't for him, they would have lost two princesses. There would have been two more funerals... Ten of them were waiting. Two guardsmen died from this monster's attack, and eight from Lady Sorrowflame's flame. Their bodies were unrecognizable, and she had no idea what she would say to their families. That they were unlucky enough to be in the path of a monster from myths and fairy tales? It was another monster, another unnatural monstrosity coming to their planet, only this time it served their so-called ally. She had no idea how they would resolve this situation, but she wouldn't let it go. Then there was this strange and terrifying man, a monster of his own kind. He also helped them, although it was not out of good will. He had some dark plans, didn't want to talk to her and left the city right after the fight. Finally, there was the matter of Madam Razz. The woman was once again the nice old lady everyone knew and liked. But for a moment, she was someone scary and ruthless... Someone similar to the Shadow Weaver from Adora and Catra's stories.

But the worst was behind them. Meanwhile, Adora... She hasn't told anyone yet about what happened in the basement under the castle. The knight who accompanied her also did not want to say anything, claiming that it was The Princess Of Power's matter and only she could tell them everything if she so wished. They could only be sure that something terrible had happened there. Something that shocked her deeply. She hadn't seen Adora like

this in Years. Since… since they lost her mother… She hadn't paid enough attention back then. She was too caught up in fighting the war and her own grief… And furious at the world that had taken her mother away from them. Now she could clearly see that her friend was suffering. She blamed herself for something again, she thought it had something to do with Light Hope. Until now, they hadn't thought much about the treacherous AI, although Adora was still afraid of her and Catra hated her for what it had done to it by digging into its worst memories... Had it discovered some secret related to the ancient AI?

The fact that Lady Cala turned out to be a traitor didn't even surprise anyone. All along they had the impression that this woman was hiding some secret, but... Not like this one. She was another monster, but hidden behind a beautiful face. They could suspect her of various things, even of being associated with Shadow Weaver... But not that she would turn out to be... To be what? She had no idea that someone could hide such monstrosity... She saw with her own eyes that her heart was pierced by a blade, but the wound closed almost immediately. It seemed as if she didn't even feel the thrust, as if it was nothing important. She-Ra could heal wounds, both her own and those of others, especially now, after the destruction of the Heart and the release of magic, but this was something completely different. As if the laws of science and magic did not apply to this being, as if it was above them. The creature that hid behind that beautiful face was not a monstrosity in appearance, after all, both Etheria and the galaxy were inhabited by various peoples, and not all of them were pretty by her standards of beauty... In fact, even in her monstrous form, Lady Cala was in strangely attractive. No, evil was hidden in her heart. She wanted to kill the Spinerella children and for no reason at all, she never even talked to them... It looked like she wanted to hurt them just for her own fun. If only she had been just a little slower… Now that monstrosity screamed in its prison beneath her feet. She ordered the guards guarding her to be extremely careful... She knew that no prison would prevent someone who was determined... and had outside help from escaping.

However, they won, although not exactly as they would have liked. Meanwhile, Frosta... The girl was lying unconscious in the hospital. The spell cast by Shadow Weaver almost killed her... He would have done it if not for the girl's vitality and She-Ra's magic, which, however, was not able to completely heal her. Frosta looked half dead, cold and barely breathing. Her strange creature was in her room, wrapping itself around her as if it were a blanket. The medics and healers initially wanted to take him out of her room, but Netossa convinced them that Shogi's presence could help the Ice Princess recover in a very literal way. As proof, she showed her healed arm, which she had broken during a trip with Catra to this ancient city... However, the girl's condition was not improving and they did not know how to help her... They also did not know why Shadow Weaver did this to her. Of all the princesses, she had the least contact with the Dark Sorcerer. Was it Lonnie who convinced her to do this, to please her allies by depriving the People's Republic of Snow of the only threat to their rule? She had no idea. Mermista, who was present, didn't remember much. Scarlet, Lonnie's right hand and sorceress, cast a spell on her and the ruler of Salinea felt as if everything around her was hostile. She admitted that she was the one who threw Frosta into the line of fire because she thought it was an enemy hiding in the form of an ice princess. Perhaps she wasn't the target of Shadow Weaver's attack... Entrapta was there too... The dark sorcerer had a reason to resent her. After all, she was the one who deprived her of power in the Horde, or maybe she helped Catra do it. Hordak's former Right Hand was vengeful and unforgiving... She would not hesitate to kill Entrapta just to repay her for past grudges. They didn't know anything for sure yet. Shadow Weaver sat in her old cell, although Catra suggested that they lock her in the same cell as Lady Cala. Maybe she will do that in the future, but for now they need to question her. She was afraid of this. This woman was a master manipulator and she didn't know what other tricks she might have up her sleeve. The only thing that was certain was that he had to keep an eye on Catra, because the cat girl might have another breakdown.

They may have captured Shadow Weaver, but Lonnie captured Empress Eridani. This was a terrible blow to the alliance. Abigail was its most powerful and loyal member. Her loss put the entire project into question. How can he guarantee the safety of his alliance members when he can't even protect one of them at his own wedding, on his own planet? He must free her as soon as possible, otherwise everything they have achieved in all these years since the defeat of Horde Prime. Only it won't be that simple. He doesn't want to wage another war, this time with the People's Rebellion, especially since they were threatened not only by Horde Prime's heirs, but by new, completely unknown forces, as they had just found out. The universe turned out to be much larger than they had ever imagined, and much darker than anyone could have imagined.

A fire also broke out in the city when a distillery built by former Horde technicians was set on fire by the Empress's guards during a fight with Lonnie. The fire did not spread because the fire brigade was on high alert even before the Alarm was announced. During such events, it often happened that someone misfired a firework. Someone also broke into the power plant and terrorized the employees. Everyone said the attacker looked just like Lady. Ka. Was it someone like Double Trouble, a shapeshifting spy and trickster? Or maybe it was someone else. She remembered that Catra had claimed that the Lord Admiral's left hand was a clone of the same scientist who had created it. Could it be one of Lady Ka's sisters? Did she work for Lonnie or Shadow Weaver?

And to make matters worse, they lost Entrapta and Swiftwind somewhere. Normally she wouldn't care much about this. The inventor princess was easily distracted around new technology, Swiftwind went with Frosta, but before that he was organizing the celebration, so perhaps he was just lost somewhere because he had to take care of some important organizational matters. However, there were other possibilities. They could have been kidnapped or even worse. No, they couldn't entertain such thoughts for now... They had to hold on to the hope that everything was fine. With all these problems, the fact that the Victory Museum had been robbed seemed irrelevant ... except for

the fact that its guards swore that the pirate captain was a tall winged woman in a mask. They didn't say it directly, but they certainly suspected it was their dead queen, or maybe they didn't want to acknowledge it? After all, even she found it hard to believe ... that her mother was alive... She stole many less valuable artifacts stolen by Horde Prime and Adora's old sword. She remembered demanding that Adora give it back to her, but it made no sense. After all, she never wanted this Weapon… In fact, she never saw her Mom ever have a weapon in her hand…. It must have had something to do with her final moments on the other side of the portal... She was almost glad that her father had only sent her a short note telling her that she had to leave Brightmoon on urgent matters. She was almost not angry with him, after all, he was probably on a case related to recent events. It's a pity that he also took Auntie Casta with him, but I guess her skills would be more useful to him... after all, her aunt didn't know anything about dark magic, interplanetary politics or suppressing Rebellions, although to be honest, her knowledge in these areas was also limited. She just hoped that nothing would happen to them.

„Well, I guess it's nothing from the wedding night. she said to her husband. Bow smiled at her reassuringly and said.

„I'll make it up to you, I promise.” he kissed her on the forehead. She smiled at him, but then Netossa snorted.

„Half of wedding nights are like this. Spinny and I were so exhausted that we simply went to bed and guess what? We don't regret it at all” she said, and her wife added

„Actually, I kind of miss it now. I don't remember the last time I slept soundly through the whole night. And it won't get better. – she smiled, rubbing her belly, and everyone laughed, although she felt a strange feeling of anxiety at the thought that this would soon happen to her, just like to Mermista... The ruler of Salinea sat gloomily, staring ahead. She blamed herself for what happened to Frosta, completely unnecessarily. It was the sorceress and Shadow Weaver's fault, she used Magic

inappropriately. Sea Hawk stood next to her, his hand on his wife's shoulder. The captain's happy and optimistic mood disappeared. He was more concerned about his wife's emotional state than anyone present. Despite his risk-taking nature and love of adventure, he was very caring. He did well during the evaluation, along with Bow. In fact, they did too well, the deserted city making it easier for Lonnie and the others to escape.

Apart from them, in the Council Room there was Catra, who was nervously pacing around the room. She wagged her tail strongly and Melog changed colors, although they were not as expressive as before, which clearly showed the emotions boiling in his companion's heart. Catra would probably like to go somewhere else. But it was hard to say where. Whether with Shadow Weaver or Lady Cala. Both women had hurt her wife, though in different ways... And with Shadow Weaver, she had old scores that needed settling. Adora looked thoughtfully out the window, thinking about what happened in the underground. She was worried about her. They will have to talk about it after the meeting, because leaving such matters alone could end very badly. General Juliette was still reeling from the shock of what her daughter's companion turned out to be, but apart from that, she seemed to be in good condition. Ambassadors Tuo and John Kilthem were present and looked very depressed. A woman from Eridani because of the kidnapping of her cousin, and a warrior from Bellum was disappointed that he did not take part in the fight because he drank too much, the inhabitants of his planet were famous for having a very weak head. Minister Shu had been dozing off on the table, she had allowed herself to relax for the first time in years during Victory Day, and now she was exhausted. Scorpia and Perfuma were absent because they wanted to recover from what happened. She wasn't surprised, after all, they were the ones who almost died during the night's events. She sighed and ordered person she needed to talk to be brought in

It was Lord Admiral Antares. Seeing her father enter, Catra turned to him, smiling broadly, and the Lord Admiral nodded at her in response, smiling as well, though much more reservedly. They didn't know what happened to him during the night's events,

except that nothing happened to him. Lady Ka was with him, smiling as always, as if she was planning to hurt someone. However, the person she called Catra's father for was not there.

„Where is Lady Sorrowflame?„ She asked sharply.

„Unfortunately, she couldn't come here.” replied the Lord Admiral in an unimpressed tone.

„I called her about what she did last night!” she shouted, angry that her orders were being ignored. The Lord Admiral sighed and replied in the same dispassionate voice as before.

„I didn't talk about it earlier, because in some regions of the galaxy, beings like her are met with prejudice, but I think it's worth clarifying some issues so that there are no misunderstandings between us. As you probably already know, Lady Sorrowflame is a dragon, and an unusually old one, as it still remembers the times of Lost Golarion. What is much more important, however, is that he is also a vampire, i.e. an undead that feeds on the life forces of living beings, and an extremely talented necromancer, i.e. a person dealing with death magic. It has been serving our family for generations. Because of her nature, walking in the light of day makes it difficult for her.„ when he said the word "Ours", he glanced at Catra, as if to emphasize that she was also a part of it. The Grand Marshal shuddered and said.

„I met one vampire in Mystacor... I managed to defeat him with great difficulty. He wanted to devour me, just like Castaspella and her assistant…”

The Lord Admiral nodded in approval.

„A ravenous and feral vampire is a dangerous opponent indeed, but most modern vampires do not feed on sentient beings and are civilized, and Lady Sorrowflame is one of the most respected scholars in... her field in the Galaxy... „ he said seriously, and she asked, smiling. askew.

„So will Lady Sorrowflame answer for what she did today?” she looked seriously at the Lord Admiral, who smiled at her slightly, almost imperceptibly, and said briefly.

„NO.”

That one word echoed in silence throughout the room. Only now did she notice that Catra's father's attitude had changed. Before he was polite, even friendly, but now he became authoritative and cold. He looked down at her. As if he was judging her and saw her as incompetent. She had the impression that he saw her as a naive child playing as an adult. She didn't like it. In Lady Ka's only eye she saw contempt and amusement. The others saw it too, even Adora and Mermista despite their mental state. Catra seemed confused, and Bow stood by her side, showing support. She tried to sound calm, but at the same time show her strength... She wanted to be like her mother.

„Lord Admiral Felix Antares. Your scholar is responsible for the death of eight guards and almost killed my friends, rulers of two kingdoms!”

Lord Admiral Antares shrugged.

“These are collateral damage... That's what happens in war.” his voice was calm, but his attitude indicated that the topic was over for him and he was going to leave, but she didn't let him.

„You won't hold your subordinate accountable...„ This time she could barely control her anger.

„Of course not... In fact, for helping in defeat the creature born from the darkness among the stars, I decided to award it the Order of the Silver Wolf, it is one of the highest decorations awarded in the former Tarak. I also made her the Archchancellor of the newly established magical university on Taurus. It's very little, but I couldn't do much more to reward a dragon that has lived for thousands of years.” replied the Lord Admiral with surprise in his voice.

For the first time in years, she had no idea what to say. How could you reward someone who caused the death of several brave soldiers... Bow spoke first. Which was good, because she was close to losing her temper.

„We on Etheri do not recognize the concept of collateral damage. For us, every life is sacred."

Catra's father shrugged again.

„I did not come here to conduct ideological discussions, because it is a waste of time, of which people in my position never have much. The main reason I came to this meeting is the information I wanted to give you." he pointed to Lady Ka, who bowed mockingly at them and said.

„I humbly and obediently report that Princess Entrapta has been kidnapped by rebel forces, and is in their hands."

She swore so badly several times that it made Bow blush, and Spinnerella looked reproachfully at her wife, because it was from Netossa that she picked up most of her juiciest swear words.

„How did this happen!" she asked, and Lady Ka answered her, still smiling slightly.

„Together we guarded a prisoner, an assassin who tried to assassinate the Lord Admiral, but unfortunately he was rescued by his comrades, including the woman you call Lonnie. Entrapta followed the attackers, I personally assume that someone cast a mind control spell on her."

She didn't believe Lady Ka. This woman looked like someone who lied as easily as she breathed. She was about to accuse her of lying when Mermisa spoke up.

„It's possible. That's when... I lost control of myself." the sea princess's voice almost broke. "Then when I attacked Frosta, I thought the red-haired woman who was with Lonnie had cast a spell on me."

Catra's eyes widened in understanding.

„Her name is Scarlet and she was a cadet like me. Then, when we were in the Lost City, she used a similar spell on Frosta, and she attacked me because of it. Lonnie, in turn, tried to take control of me with such a staff... „ she explained, and then General Juliette spoke up.

„This explains how the Empress was kidnapped. Her guards explained that Lonnie had held a staff to their head and then she ordered them to surrender.”

They looked at each other. They already knew that Lonnie had mind control magic, but they didn't realize how much of a threat it was. Seeing their consternation, the Lord Admiral smiled faintly and said.

„I'll leave you alone to think about what you've learned. Soon I'm going to wage a war for which you didn't have time, and after recent events, you probably won't find it. However, before I leave your planet, I would be very happy to talk to my daughter and daughter-in-law. I also plan to meet Shadow Weaver if there is room for me in line.” he started to leave without waiting for her reaction, and Lady Ka followed him, but before he left the meeting room, he stopped, turned to her and said.

„Another thing. I didn't see fit to correct you earlier, Queen, but I guess it's time to let you know. Some time ago, the Taurus government granted me the title of Lord Protector, and you should address me as such.” before she could say anything, he left the council room. Then she could fully surrender to the emotions boiling in her heart.

"What…" She barely refrained from calling Catra's father names, but the cat girl looked at them apologetically, as if the Lord Admiral's behavior was her fault and said.

„ I'll try to talk to him later. Maybe I can get something from him...„ she didn't seem convinced by her words. She smiled at her

friend to comfort her.

„Let's not worry about him for now. First we need to focus on how to free the captives.„ seeing John Kilthem raise his hand, she added... „Without destroying a significant part of the planet and killing thousands of innocents?” at this point the ambassador plopped down on his chair, clearly sad. General Juliette spoke up.

„I guess you'll do what you always did during the war. Io means you will carry out a daring rescue mission that will succeed despite initial difficulties.” Everyone laughed, except for Adora, who said in a dark voice.

„It won't be that easy...”

They looked at her in surprise and Adora continued.

„Then, when we took out Shadow Weaver, we met Rosie, the deaf girl we had previously encountered on Ikarus. She was very nice, but now something strange has happened to her. She started glowing and lunged at me. She... She almost beat me. If it wasn't for... someone else, I would have lost... Her blows were draining my magic... I'm not sure who she is, but as I was fighting her, a voice rang out in my head... It told me that... I was a traitor ... that I had failed... I'm not sure what he was referring to... But I guess it had to do with what Light Hope was trying to do.” she finished and lowered her head

She felt cold sweat break out on her back. He remembered what the Ancient AI wanted to do. Then, using the power of She-Ra and the runestones, she almost destroyed most of the life in the galaxy, to which she contributed significantly. If Adora hadn't broken the sword, all would have been lost, very literally. However, if her friend mentioned Light Hope, it meant that…

„Are you implying that this girl has some connection with the First Ones?”

Adora stared ahead for a few moments before she began to speak in a quiet, barely audible voice.

„Lady Cala took us to the underground... There I met Heart Gift... She was very nice, but... She is the daughter of Light Hope and Mara. I know, it seems weird. Lady Cala… She told Heart Gift the truth… About what happened to her mothers… about me murdering Light Hope….” Adora closed her eyes and tears ran down her cheeks. Catra stood up and placed a hand on her shoulder, she teleported next to her friend, and Bow and Mermista walked up to her.

„It's not your fault... If I hadn't tried to use my heart to strengthen our power... Perhaps we would have succeeded somehow...„ she said, feeling a pang of remorse, because what she said was not just a way to console her, but also the honest truth.

„ I am also guilty, because after losing my kingdom, I was the one who pushed the most to implement this plan. Mermista said seriously.

„And also mine... If I hadn't escalated this war, if I hadn't pushed so hard to win... If I hadn't pulled that lever, none of this would have happened.” Catra said, wincing at the pain of guilt.

„Listen, it's not about who's guilty. None of us are blameless, but the most guilty are Shadow Weaver and those who reprogrammed Light Hope and created the Heart. Bow said. She smiled at him, somewhat comforted, although there were still fears inside her, because in her castle there were not only a Ruthless Manipulator with enormous magical skills and an inhuman monster, but also Si, which was the work of a civilization that almost destroyed all intelligent life in the Galaxy... The castle, which she had previously considered her safe home, was no longer such a place

For the next few hours, they discussed what they should do, until she finally came to the conclusion that they would not come to any new conclusions, so she ordered everyone to go to bed, because they still had to interrogate the prisoners. However,

before she went to sleep, she had to take care of one more thing. She said goodbye to Bow and teleported away. She found herself in a small guest room, similar to the one she had placed Shadow Weaver in. The one who stayed here was also a bigger person, but not entirely...

Hordak was playing with his child. She was completely unprepared for this sight. This will make the whole thing much more difficult.

„Do you already know what happened to my wife?" he asked in a hard, rough voice without turning towards her. She sighed heavily and told him everything she had learned from Lady Ka. He didn't even look at her the whole time, even though she felt something boiling inside him. When she finished, he said in a reproachful voice.

„How is it that in five years of being in the most dangerous place on Etheri, nothing happened to her, but every time she meets with you, her life is in danger?"

She sighed heavily, because he was quite right.

„We will do everything to free her." assured Hordak. Never in her life did she think that she would have to explain herself to the ruler of the Etherian Horde.

„ You are not doing me any favours, after all, you Claim that she is your friend, although in fact you can do what you want anyway and there is nothing I can do about it.." he said bitterly, slowly standing. Even though he had a child in his arms, he still looked menacing. "Arrange care for my child. I propose that it be placed in Scorpia's care during my absence. Of all of you, I consider her the most trustworthy.

She blinked twice as she realized what Hordak had said.

„You can't... you are... „ she wanted to say, but he interrupted her.

„Your father and aunt have issued me safe-conduct and want me to accompany them, so please leave me alone to say goodbye and

prepare for the journey. If you have any questions, ask your relatives. It's time for me...

Once again that day, she had no idea what to say, so since she probably wouldn't learn anything new from Hordak, she decided to leave him alone and teleported away.

Chapter End Notes

> You've been waiting a while for this chapter. Feel free to comment.

Before you hit the road

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

He smiled as the young queen left him. He felt no remorse for deceiving her a bit, especially since Entrapta herself had told him not to tell anyone. Of course, that wasn't what she had in mind, but it would still be best if no one found out anything. Catra probably trusted her father too much too. On this matter, he understood it, after all, he had loved Horde Prime all his life.

A few hours earlier, he was furiously walking around the room assigned to him and the child. When the alarm sounded, he immediately reported to the guard just in case, so as not to be accused of contributing to what was going to happen... Mikah, Castaspella and that ridiculous sorceress who had explained Shadow Weaver's plan to them, went their separate ways. He was not taken to the shelters. The frightened guards passed him around one by one, until he finally found himself in the care of a clone serving in the Brightmoon guard, who introduced himself as Brother Blade, who took him to a small house where he was to wait for his loved ones. Brother Blade treated him like all the other clones, with a mixture of fear and respect. This didn't surprise him, after all, he was the first of his kind to not only free himself from Horde Prime's tyranny, but also kill him, or at least one of his bodies. He waited alone for an hour until that strange insectoid woman his wife had befriended brought him the Child. It was happy to see him, so his wife's new friend left it for him and then went away to rest. Well she looked exhausted, sometimes the Child could be extremely intense. However, he had not heard anything from Entrapta and he was becoming more and more worried. However, after a few hours, their shared datapad, which was based on Galactic Horde technology, responded. He immediately took it in his hands and looked at his wife's face.

„I'm glad to see you! I hope you weren't too worried!„ Entrapta exclaimed happily, smiling broadly. She looked genuinely happy. He already knew that his wife tried to always smile, even when she was sad or angry, but he had learned to recognize her true moods. This time she looked realy happy.

„I was worried about you. Someone attacked Brightmoon, but the threat appears to have passed. Me and the baby are safe. – he showed the screen to the child, who was happy to see his mother. Entrapta greeted her offspring and then turned to him.

„I am my dearest on a wonderful spaceship from outside the Empire! It's called Deadly Sword Of Burning Fury and it's so amazing!” said his wife and squealed with delight. He smiled at her, filled with relief, but then he felt anxious.

„Where is this ship and how did you get on it?” he asked, trying not to let his wife hear the fear in his voice.

„You know, there was a shooting, and then I went with Worgdak to this ship. Because I had to help her, and now we're going to Dryl! It will be nice to visit my old home.”

Now he felt real fear. Wrongdak was with Shadow Weaver and Dryll was in the possession of Lonnie and her People’s Rebellion and they had evil intentions towards him and his wife. Had she been abducted and didn't even realize it? In the case of Entrapta, this was quite likely.

„Are you safe? Is no one threatening you with anything? Is there anyone else here with you, apart from Wrongdak, that you know? Someone unusual?„ he asked, no longer hiding his fears. Then another person entered the frame. She was hanging upside down, but neither her hair nor her clothes were hanging, as if the ceiling had its own gravity. For a moment he thought it was Catra, the person looked so much like her.

„Hey Grumpy, if you're looking for someone special, you've got me. After all, I am absolutely perfect, amazing and unique.” she

said in a dull voice, and now he realized that it was definitely not Catra. She was very much like her though.

“This is Eti, you know, our Catra's sister.” said his wife as if the fact that Catra had a sister was common knowledge. The fact that the cat-girl had more relatives didn't sit well with him, let alone the fact that one of them was on the same ship as his beloved. However, Eti seemed... close to him somehow. There was something familiar about her, though he couldn't pinpoint what.

“She has an amazing prosthetic, I think it's some kind of ancient artefact!” continued his wife. “I just can't wait to examine her! Her shoes are amazing too! Oh Hordaku, this is such a wonderful place. - she squealed again in a voice filled with delight. He involuntarily smiled seeing Entrapta's joy. - You know, I think I'll introduce you to the others!” she exclaimed and began to walk around the deck, showing him more passengers. .

„This is Rosie, she is Eti's friend.” a white-haired girl appeared in front of the screen, waved at him, smiling friendly, and then started moving her hands, and a voice began to come out of her gloves.

„Hello! I'm very happy I could meet you. Your brother, Wrongak, has told us all a lot about you. He is always very nice to everyone and saved the Comrade General and your wife is very cool.” Rosie explained, and Eti then walked up to her and hugged her.

„By the way, Rosie is my girlfriend and we love each other very much.” Catra's sister said, and the white-haired girl blushed. Entrapta then went on to show him the other passengers on that ship. Next was a silver-scaled lizard with multiple cybermetic implants. He looked at him and made a surprised face.

„This is Alatar. He helped me establish a secure connection to your datapad. – said his wife, and Alatar added.

„I also loaded your pad with many applications, although many of them will only be useful when you gain access to the Internet. I

also gave you some games in case you were ever bored.” the lizard said in a confused voice. Entrapta left him and went to some saihe girl who had her arm in a sling. She introduced herself as Itel, but said nothing else, seeming to be lost in dark thoughts. Then his wife ran to Ireanis and a burgundy-haired woman who was discussing something intensely with a not very competent sorceress who gave him a happy smile. Entrapta didn't want to disturb them, so she moved on to the next passengers. They were a red-haired girl, short but muscular, and a winged horse with a horn that looked oddly familiar. The girl was explaining something to the horse, but after a while they saw the datapad and the redhead waved at it, and the horse tried to say something, but Entrapta didn't let him say a word

„This is Lilka Wagardotir. She's an orc like Huntara, and that horse-bird hybrid is Swiftwind, but you already know him, so we won't bother with him any longer.” she left the confused horse and went to look for more passengers. She stood in front of three people, one of whom was a large lizard, the second a blond-haired boy, and the third a dark-skinned woman. The first two straightened up as if frightened, but the woman looked at him with a murderous look. He felt like he should know them

„These are Rogelio, Kyle and Lonnie. Maybe you remember them, they served in your Horde! Kyle, Rogelio, Lonnie, do you have something to say to your former commander!?” Entrapta said and the Blond haired boy looked sheepish and said.

„Oh Hordak... it's good to see you... after so many years and it's a very strange thing with our rebellion, isn't it? I hope you are fine?| said the boy, and the lizard nodded. The woman didn't say anything, her look said more than a thousand words.

„And now it's time for you to meet your old friend... Imp, come here!” Entrapta called out, and a creature he hadn't seen in five years flew into the lens. A being that he brought to life with his own hands. The Imp was dressed in a People's Rebellion uniform made especially for him, although he had a small, wide-brimmed hat on his head. He looked at his former companion for a

moment. For many years he was the only being he could trust. The imp was his only companion, his confidant, although back then he couldn't name the bond that connected them. Actually, in a way he was closer to him than Entrapta. He was there for him through his triumphs and through all his moments of doubt when his self-hatred seemed to consume him... And he was also a witness to all his despicable deeds... Including the one he didn't dare to tell even his loved one... They hadn't seen each other since when Horde Prime arrived, but all this time he had been wondering what he would say to him... But now he had no idea what he could tell him... He wasn't even sure who they were to each other... Father and son, friends, brothers... probably all of those things. bit by bit…

„Hello, my little... my friend.” he said, feeling tears flowing down his cheeks.

„I am glad to see you, Hordak.” said the Imp, reproducing Entrapta's voice from when they had just met. Tears also ran down the Winged Being's face. He had no idea what he could say next.

„I missed you. I've been missing you all this time.” he said, feeling his voice break.

„Me too, indeed.” said Imp, this time in Shadow Weaver's voice. Now he regretted not giving him his own voice. Back then, he didn't think of him as a companion, but only as a useful tool. Another mistake he made... Maybe he'll fix it someday.

„I'd like you to meet someone.” he said and showed him the Child. They both looked at each other in amazement and then walked up to the screen, looking at each other closely.

„Dad! Look! He likes me!„ exclaimed the Child and laughed happily, and the Imp echoed him.

„This is your brother.„ he said, finally deciding who the creature on the other side of the screen was. He let them stare at each other

for a moment longer, and then he said.

„I hope you're doing well here... And now, my dear, go to my brother, because I need to talk to him.” he said to Entrapta.

“Probably my dearest! Wrongdak performed bravely during the fight. He even saved the life of the Comrade General!” she said, running through the ship's corridors. Wrongdak was in a small room, probably a workshop, where he was mending clothes. When he saw him, his brother straightened up and spoke in a voice full of concern.

„Hello brother... ugh... I can explain everything!”

„It's okay.... You didn't do anything wrong... Entrapta, could you stand in front of the screen, because I have something very important to tell you, „ when his wife did as he asked, he told her about Shadow Weaver's visit and what he learned from her.

„Oh Hordak, you could have told me about it!” she said in a sad voice, but she didn't seem particularly angry... She was better for him than he deserved.

„I didn't have the courage to tell you about it, but the most important thing is that this time she was telling the truth.”

To his surprise, Entrapta nodded.

„Yes, that might be true. Although the technology the Lord Admiral has is wonderful, he is probably not a good person. Lady Ka tried to shoot Itel, and Graag also serves him. He...„ she didn't finish because Wrongdak interrupted her.

„He wanted to sell me like I was a thing.” there was such hatred in his brother's voice that he had never expected from him, but he was not surprised. There was a rage inside him that he hadn't felt in a long time.

„We will seek justice another time. I will soon be going on a journey with Shadow Weaver to try to keep us all safe and maybe

find redemption.”

„Shadow Weaver was captured by Catra. But Ireanis knows everything. You can trust her.” said his brother with great confidence in his voice. He, in turn, wondered who would kill the dark sorceress first, Catra or her father.

„It doesn't change anything then. I have to finish for now. Take care of yourself, he said and hung up.”

It was a few hours earlier. He decided not to tell the queen anything, because he didn't know how much he could trust Catra, and he was sure that Glimmer would tell her all about it, and she would definitely talk to her father, and that would complicate everything. He could also stand in the way of their expedition. He had the means to make the four of them disappear if he felt it was in his best interests, or at least try to do so. He was a great warrior, especially in the armor Entrapta had made for him, and Mikah had survived many years on the island beast, but he wasn't sure the other two would be able to handle it if the Lord Admiral sent his troops against them. He also doubted Catra would believe him or anyone else, he knew how hard it was to accept the truth about those you adored. He learned the truth far too late.

He smiled at the Child and said.

„I think you'll like Aunt Scorpia....”

„ It was a fucking failure. " Lady Ka growled in the Dwarvespeak, a language no one here knew.

„Not at all!” said the Lord Admiral walking next to him in the same language. She looked at him in surprise.

„We failed to capture your second daughter...„ she said, but Antares waved his hand. He was in an exceptionally good mood after talking to the little queen.

„It wasn't our main goal. It was just an additional opportunity that we took advantage of, but unfortunately it didn't work out. In the grand scheme of things, however, this doesn't change anything. Sooner or later the girl will fall into our hands, and we will bring her back to the right path. But now we know where she is... And in other respects we have won. And how much did it cost us?”

„Keshar and Graag were injured, but they will recover soon. In addition, I lost three mutts and two others were seriously injured ... but they where a cannon fodder... You're right, the costs were minimal, but what kind of victory are you talking about?” she looked at the Lord Admiral and saw a blue spark in his biological eye.

„The young queen needed our support in the fight against an enemy they had never encountered before. Moreover, it turned out that she was unable to defend her guests and subjects. Empress of Eridani was kidnapped, as was this Entrapta. Princess Frosta is seriously injured, it is unknown whether she will survive. In one word, it's a disaster. Soon they will probably ask us for help. While the Queen was showing off her incompetence, my daughter captured Shadow Weaver, the most hated person on the planet.” she heard satisfaction, even joy, in her commander's voice. He rarely showed emotion, but now he was positively radiant with joy. Well, he made sense, but she still had her doubts.

„Aren't you worried about what that dark witch might say to your daughter? She may know... the wrong version of the truth. What will you do if he starts talking.”

This time the Lord Admiral smiled. Others said that her smile was ugly, that it inspired fear, but compared to the smile of her commander when he took off the mask of a great leader and statesman, even for a moment, it was like the joyful smile of a baby.

„Let her talk. I'm even counting on it to some extent. Shadow Weaver manipulated Catra and Adora for Years. She lied and bent

everyone to her will. She did everything to make my daughter hate her. Whatever he tells her now, to Catra it will be another lie. If she then hears the same thing from someone else, she will also consider it a lie, because it will sound the same as the words of the woman who tormented her all her life. It will be even better if the queen wlll believe the dark sorceress. Fractures will then appear between them, which will only need to be widened."

She looked at her commander with approval. His ability to bend others to his will always amazed her. She never had the patience for something like this, unless fear and suffering were involved.

„What about Entrapta? While being with your other daughter and her friends, she may hear some things that are not entirely favorable to you." she said, thinking about the fact that that idiot had seen her trying to shoot that elf.

„Well, I must admit that you could have played it better, but leadership is about turning mistakes into successes. When we free the prisoners, it turns out that your sister killed her and burned the body. Another of the young queen's countless failures. Of course, we won't let someone so bright go to waste, although it may take a little persuasion... or a small favor from Lady Sorrowflame. In fact, we will be doing future generations a great favor by ensuring that such a brilliant mind survives in the form of a vampire...„ Antares's voice was gentle and thoughtful.

„Or we'll turn her into a ghoul. Then it will eat the corpses in such cute little pieces." she said, parodying the purple-haired idiot.

„ It was quite macabre, but also quite funny. – the Lord Admiral said, a hint of a smile appearing on his face.

They walked for a while, enjoying the good mood, until after a while the Lord Admiral said.

„You'll stay here for a while. Someone must supervise the release of my second daughter, as well as the solution of the Queen's problem. In this second matter, be very careful, because one

careless step... can ruin everything. It's better that you do nothing than for anyone to find out about our plans. As for my second daughter, try to get her into our hands, you may have to fake her death... Try to capture her friends. Thanks to this, you will be able to put pressure on her to behave sensibly... You can do whatever you want with your sister, she is a traitor after all... Appoint someone to command your men in your absence. Take a hundred or two, but the more disciplined ones. I'll give you a dozen or so of my soldiers. Once you deal with this problem, when you come back, you will have a mission to create a secret police in my new empire. And one more thing, you'll probably be happy to hear that Lady Sorrowflame is here to stay. He claims he's looking for some ancient artifacts left by my daughter's-in-law relatives. Help her in this matter too, I don't care about the power they hide, but about preventing a possible catastrophe that they could cause. You will receive a mystical communicator, not as safe as the mirrors I had before, but still extremely useful.„ he said, and then his daughter approached them.

„I'd like to talk to you.” Catra said. The Lord Admiral signaled her and she moved into the shadows so they could discuss their business.

Lord Admiral Felix Antares put a slight smile on his face and turned to his Daughter.

„What's bothering you, my dear?” he asked, fully understanding what she came to him with.

„You shouldn't be so hard on Glimmer. She's my friend and... She ruled Etheria really well during the war when I... led the Horde. Maybe we didn't do so well yesterday, but she still managed to fend off that monster. Everyone makes mistakes.” he felt anger in her voice, but also pleading.

„I am a man who is accustomed to commanding men while fighting an enemy so terrible that the entire galaxy fears him.

That's why I'm a bit rough. Maybe I was a little too harsh on your friend. But everything I said is true. Lady Sorrowflame is one of my best subordinates. I can't punish her for doing her thing. I feel sorry for these guardsmen and their families, but such things happen in war. Perhaps your queen will learn this... She should, considering what may lie ahead."

Catra frowned and flattened her ears. She wagged the tip of her tail as if she was worried. Her pet, although more and more sure that Melog was much more than an ordinary animal, looked at him carefully, shimmering with different colors.

„What do you mean? You sound like you know something very important that you haven't told us yet." she said, looking him straight in the eye. He was silent for a moment, as if considering an answer, before speaking.

„The center of the Pact Worlds is the Absalom Space Station. It is huge, inhabited by millions of beings who live there permanently and just as many who stopped there while traveling through the universe. Absalom Station is the center of the Galaxy, and quite literally, because it is where the Starstone is located. It is the most powerful artifact we know. Not only does it provide power to the entire station, but it also enables the use of drift drive, the most efficient way to travel between stars, and in every way superior to anything Horde Prime had at his disposal. It is like a beacon for ships traveling through the Drift dimension. Moreover, it allows you to instantly return to Absalom, making it one of the most important places in the universe."

„But what does this have to do with Etheria?" she asked, although her eyes showed that she had already guessed the answer.

„There is a second Starstone on Etheria." he said, carefully watching the gravity of the whole situation sink in. Catra buried her face in her hands and Melog cuddled up to her.

„The destruction of the Heart was not the end of the nightmare... But it explains everything, now I understand why Etheria was

always so important... So special.” she moaned and added. “They'll come for him, right? Other powers in the galaxy? Is that why you're telling me this?” she looked at him again. He nodded and answered briefly.

„Yes...„ then he thought about it, because he wasn't sure whether to reveal everything to her at once, the issue of time also worried him, but it was better to insert the needle with one push. „There's something else. Absalom Station is located where the planet Golarion once existed. This is where the Starstone came from... It had the power to turn people into Gods.”

Catra grimaced in irritation.

„What does this nonsense have to do with all this?” she said contemptuously. He looked at her with absolute seriousness.

„It's not nonsense. Such matters are documented. From what Lady Sorrowflame told me, the queen fought at night with a creature that was in fact a minor deity or demigod... They are not perfect, omnipotent and omniscient beings, but they have great power and sometimes they are to be reckoned with. Legends and stories tell of four mortals who achieved ascension through the power of the stone. They were Aroden, the now dead god of humanity, Cayden Cailean „the Lucky Drunk”, Norgorber „the Reaper of Reputation” and Iomadae “the Inheritor of Aroden”. I suspect your wife may be connected to this Artifact in some way.

He saw the terrified understanding on his daughter's face.

„But it's impossible... Adora can't become one of them, of these gods... She can't...”

He put his hand on her shoulder and said.

„I'm not saying this will happen, no one knows how your Starstone works, but the fact that this artifact is on your planet is an indisputable fact, but if you don't believe me, ask Lady Cali or your former… officer in charge…„ he said and went to have Lady

Sorrowflame administer the medicine to him. But as he walked, he staggered and almost fell.

„Father!” Catra called out and ran to him to support him. With her help, he managed to get up.

„Thank you, my dear... This shouldn't have happened...„ he said, smiling sadly.

„What's wrong? You are sick?” she asked with fear.

„Yes, that's the genetic flaw I told you about. She is slowly killing me... I don't have much time left, that's why I encouraged you to take over my inheritance... because if you don't do it, then... „ he lowered his voice. “Lady Sorrowflame and Lady Ka They will take over my subordinates...”

He saw the pain on her face again, but hey, a little suffering makes a better leader, but then hope appeared on the girl's face.

„Adora! Her She-Ra power can heal... She even brought me back to life once. It will definitely help you too.”

„If he agrees, I would be very glad.” he said, seeing the sea infinite possibilities opening before him.

Rechiza rubbed her forehead. She had a headache since last night. She knew that she should thank all the gods that she was alive, not to mention that nothing serious had happened to her. After all, she fought with one of the Chaugnar Faugn’s Brothers and did not fall into madness. It was something that could be told in legends. Although in truth they only succeeded because she was helped by an extremely powerful sorceress, although she was also a bit crazy, and after the fight she started behaving like some old woman with dementia. She was also helped by this man, disturbing and terrifying. He claimed to be the ruler of Carurystal, the same planet that Lady Cala came from. She didn't know much about him, except that his family had ruled the entire planet since

time immemorial and had a good reputation, although she couldn't understand the latter when looking into his cold blue eyes. This individual terrified her and seemed to know far too much for the ruler of a provincial planet of no great importance. Worse yet, he also seemed to be old, older than anyone she had ever seen, including even some of the devils and demons she had fought. He saved her, but he didn't tell her why he did it. She didn't trust him, although that might not have been the right word. She rather expected the worst from him. She knew she was at his mercy and that was actually the most frustrating thing. She was sure he would murder her without blinking an eye.

After she returned to the city, she learned that their former companion had shown Etheria her true colors. They had known for some time that Lady Cala was something inhuman, ever since she survived the explosion of explosives, but when Brightmoon's guards began to discuss what the Carurystal noblewoman had done, she asked them for details. They were both shocked by what they witnessed, so they willingly shared their experiences with her. To her, the fact that ordinary people harbor monstrous natures was nothing unusual, but to most of the inhabitants of this world it was a terrifying discovery. At first she wasn't sure who… what the creature that stood before the queen was. But when the name Yog-Sototh was mentioned, even though the guards didn't pronounce it correctly and she had to guess who they were talking about, she felt herself trying to retract antennae she didn't have in fear. She was the spawn of Yog-Sototh, one of the most feared beings existing in the galaxy. They were usually much more monstrous and completely alien in nature, although some were similar to mortals, most often humans, because the cults of a great external god were very popular among representatives of this species. Not all of them were bad, for example the legendary Demonique from the lost Golarion. But Lady Cala was wicked through and through, there was no doubt about it. Now she finally fully understood the horrors she had traveled through these weeks and what she had brought to this planet. And in her pride she was blind to such an obvious truth. Even these kids, especially the cat girl, realized that there was

something wrong with this woman. When she then analyzed all the events she had witnessed, everything became obvious. She realized with horror how lucky they were that they had not met death or a much worse fate during their journey.

She decided to inform the Archduke of what she had learned. She found Kane Adamson in the royal garden, where he was looking at these strange moons. When he heard her, he turned towards her. She shuddered when those cold blue eyes looked at her. There was something terrifying about the Archduke. When she looked at him directly it wasn't so bad, but when she looked at him out of the corner of her eye she had the impression that there was fire in his eyes and blood was dripping from his hands. She did not underestimate what her extraordinary eyesight revealed. It had cost her dearly to obtain him, and she still longed for her real eyes. She told Kane what she had learned, and the murderous-looking aristocrat smiled.

„That's what I should have expected, actually. However, at this point it is no longer our concern, although we must be much more vigilant than before. The events of yesterday cannot be repeated."

She felt something touched her.

„Did you know that Chaugnar Faugna's younger brother would come here? Did you have a purpose in this?"

The Archduke smiled indulgently at her

„And what benefit could I get from it? Make yourself a hero? It's not worth playing with the Great Old Ones, even the lesser ones. I didn't think that this statue contained the essence of one of the Young Brothers, although I should have checked it out or even blown it up as a precaution. It would have been much easier than the night fight, although at least I learned some interesting things." he rubbed his red beard with his hand.

"Do you mean that shiny guy with the sword, or maybe the old woman who seemed to know you even though this planet was cut

off from the rest of the universe for thousands of years?” she asked angrily, but Kane smiled at her surprisingly cheerfully and said…

„Yes.”

She stared at him in bewilderment for a moment, and then let out a loud, almost painful trill, a sign of indescribable rage among her species.

„I answered your question, although probably not in as much detail as you expected, but you will find out everything in due time. You have to be patient. Dr. Sidonus said this was your great virtue, like Arkan-tar's cunning.”

This time she was speechless with surprise for a moment, but then she felt her anger return.

„So it was his... your doing from the very beginning! Are you behind all this journey!” she said, and she felt anxious. How deep, both in terms of power and in terms of time, did this conspiracy reach?

But Kane shook his head.

„The doctor is only responsible for sending the ship you were on. The fact that you got into it is pure coincidence, like many other things that have happened recently. In truth, all this should seem very suspicious, but for now I have no significant evidence that any forces intervened in the course of events, but it is much easier to get entangled in the threads of fate than to break free from them.” he spoke in a scholarly tone, so incongruous with his appearance as a murderer. She felt like fluttering her antennae in surprise, and when she remembered that it was impossible, she felt her body release a pheromone of anger.

„So, what are you going to do next? You must have been a little late to ask the Queen's Hand, you won't marry She-Ra either, I guess all the important people on the planet are probably already taken. You could try to pick up the Lord Admiral, or someone from

his entourage, but it would end badly, although I'm not sure for whom.” she said, twisting her face in a malicious smile, but Kane ignored her malicious taunt and started telling her about his plans.

„First we have to go to the Singing Jungle, because the ruler there knows a lot and is favorable to us. I have a mystery to solve.” his voice was thoughtful and a little sad.

„Could you tell us a little secret, or will it break your vein?” she asked, not hiding her anger.

„I have to remember how I helped murder the original inhabitants of this planet.” he looked into her face, icy flames dancing in his blue eyes. “Is this the truth you wanted, Rechiza?”

She fell silent because she didn't know what to say, and she doubted whether there was a reasonable response to admitting to genocide on a planetary scale.

Then Queen Glimmer appeared next to them. She jumped, feeling as if she had been caught in some evil plot. In a way it was like that...

„Let me ask you directly, Archduke, if you knew who Lady Cala was and that she was working with Shadow Weaver... „ said the queen in a sharp tone, while casting some spell on him. Kane made no gesture to show that he resented the Lord of Etheria for casting a spell on him. He bowed politely and said in a polite tone

„Lady Cala belongs to one of the oldest, most respected and wealthiest families on Carurystal and is a well-liked young lady, the embodiment of every virtue important to the citizens of my world. Miss Daisy, your Shadow Weaver, was initially treated with some reserve because she was a foreigner, but she quickly gained the respect and sympathy of society. Some people whispered about the terrible accident that had left her disfigured, but almost everyone felt sorry for her, as befits an honest and noble person.” The Archduke smiled broadly and continued. “Of course, as a responsible ruler, I had some suspicions, but in a law-abiding

country like my Archduchy, suspicions are definitely too little to intervene, and I didn't want to seem like someone bending the law to suit my whim. However, if you have some time, try to ask Lady Cala about the fate of her family, it will probably help you solve some mysteries. I also want to point out that your planet was virtually unknown in the wider universe, so I couldn't suspect Miss Daisy of anything. I hope I gave you a thorough enough answer?

Judging by Glimmer's expression, that was the case. The queen rubbed her temples and asked something else.

„What are you doing here anyway?”

The Archduke shrugged.

„I'm not going to answer this question or any other question you ask me. Etheria is not a police state and welcomes anyone who wishes to come here. I would also like to point out that my presence here so far has proven to be extremely useful and I can guarantee that it will be the same in the future.”

Glimmer looked at him blankly for a moment, then wiped her face and said.

„I am to tired for another conversation like this today, especially since I have several more, much more difficult conversations ahead of me today.” and disappeared in a teleportation flash. Kane then said with appreciation in his voice.

„You have to admit that it's really good. At first, her spell had an effect on me, so I tried to talk to her while I waited for my mind to overcome the spell.” then he looked at her and asked in a much more serious tone than the one he used to address the queen. ”Over the course of my unimaginably long life, I have learned that it is much better for others to serve you willingly, so I ask you, would you like to join me? Be warned that you are risking much more than just the reward is uncertain.”

She thought for a moment and said.

„All right, because I want to find out something. This plan of yours has to do with the First Ones... They're the reason I have this.” she tapped on the metal eye. “I want to find them, meet them and take revenge, or at least die trying.”

Dilayla sighed and said.

„So much for the Lord Admiral and his past.” she looked at the Star Siblings. To her relief, Tallstar accepted the news she had brought, and wasn't even too surprised by what she said. Starla looked at her with eyes shock. Jewelstar didn't seem to fully trust her.

„ And you won't tell anyone about it?” the youngest asked. She shrugged and answered her.

„I thought about it. But who am I? Just a mere mercenary, what would my word be worth against the word of someone like Lord Admiral Antares? If the Archduke had supported us, we might have been able to give the Queen something to think about, but yes? Plus, I was traveling with Shadow Weaver, which makes me suspicious. They might think we're still following that witch's orders, especially if she starts saying what we say.”

„ How do you know if it's true at all? The woman you heard this from is definitely a reliable source? After all, she is some kind of terrorist, or at least she was associated with them . „ Jewelstar said, clearly angry with her.

„ And who were we supposed to be during all these years of fighting Horde Prime?” Tallstar turned sharply to her brother.

„Bina's nice.” she said quietly, trying not to look into the eyes of the older sister. “But I definitely believe these kids, especially Eti. She is your Catra's sister, and she must have a serious reason for choosing to wander the cosmos rather than a life of luxury that her father would be able to provide. I heard what they said among themselves... „ she closed her eyes and shook her head. –

They were full of Anger. It was Bina who tried to soothe him. She wanted to make them find some new purpose in life beyond revenge. Lilka and Alatar kind of wanted to find a place for themselves in life, but Itel... She wanted someone to pay for Kesler's Fall. – the mercenary sighed.

„Sorry if I'm interfering, but was Lilka a fiery red haired girl and Itel a green-haired Elf?„ asked the man dressed as a Fearless Armada soldier. Instead of answering his question, she jumped at him and grabbed him by the throat.

„You were wrong to eavesdrop on us." she said menacingly, ready to tighten her hand and crush his windpipe, but Starla called out.

„Leave him alone, he's my boyfriend Kay!"

She cursed inwardly. This complicated everything.

„I wasn't eavesdropping on you... „ he groaned, she could barely hear what he was saying. "I wanted to ask Starla if she had time for a little picnic before the flight." he said, took a breath with some effort and added. "I'm from Kesler. I had a sister, a red-haired girl named Lilka." he said and loosened her grip a bit, but was ready to tighten it again at any moment.

„ Yes, it was a redhead girl, short but powerfully muscled, she probably came from some farm, and Itel had short green hair and arms covered with tattoos." when she said this, tears ran down his face. At first she thought it might be the Lord Admiral's spy, but those tears… They felt all too real. She let go of him and he rubbed his neck and said.

"Itel is my friend's daughter, we are together... from Kesler and we are collecting information about Antares' activities for the Iomadae church and the stewards.„ he said. The Stewards were interplanetary police working for the authorities of the pact worlds." Antares' nefarious actions arouse the dislike of many high-ranking people, although unfortunately many others support him. That's why we need to collect evidence, but we need to be

careful because... „ He looked around nervously, as if he had only just realized that he might be being watched, he was not ideal spy material. “They say that those who are too nosy will at best end up among Lady Ka's dogs, unless he is accused of treason, then Lady Sorrowflame takes care of him, and that is... worse than death.” he said, and when he mentioned the necromancer, he shuddered.

„So you're a spy, just working for the good guys.” Dilayla said, smiling at him apologetically. „Your sister and your friend's daughter... I don't know what they were like before, but they've almost certainly changed a lot, you have to be ready for it... „ She looked at the rest and sighed. „I have to disappear now. The Archduke hired me because he fears that Etheria is threatened by a much greater evil than the Lord Admiral.” she handed Talstar a small silver tablet. – Thanks to this we will be able to contact each other. I have another one of these, paired with the one you're holding. The problem is that you have to use blood. Just a few drops are enough, but we can't prick our fingers, right? she laughed and added. „ Well, take care of yourselves... „ she said quietly and looked down. They were silent for a moment, and then she was about to turn around to go her way, but suddenly Talstar threw her arms around her neck and kissed her. She felt joy, heat spreading through her body. “Take care of yourself too.” said the former rebel.

Chapter End Notes

I apologise for the delay. I've decided to develop the Lashunty side of Rechisia a bit.

Princess of Nothingness.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Talking to the Archduke turned out to be as pointless as talking to Hordak . At that moment, she wished she had the power of Shadow Weaver or at least Empress of Eridani to command obedience to her guests and subjects regardless of any law. In fact, maybe she had that power, she wasn't sure. It just wasn't Etherian Way to impose your will on others . So she ate a big piece of her wedding cake, no one even touched it because of what happened yesterday. None of her friends had eaten anything and they were all hungry, but she was hungry for two. She didn't eat her fill of the cake, but it was enough for now. It was already late afternoon and she still had to talk to two people, first she decided to start with the one with whom it would be easier, but would talking to a monster wearing a human mask be easy?

Catra, Adora and the Brother Blade were waiting for her in the council chamber. Adora looked a bit better now, she probably got a little sleep, Catra was nervous, her tail was wagging vigorously and her eyes were darting, and Melog was walking around the corridor, purring softly, only stopping from time to time to rub against Adora. As soon as they saw her, they stood up.

„Ready to chat with Lady Cala?" she asked, smiling, although it wasn't a sincere smile.

„I still think we should talk to Shadow Weaver first." Adora said with a fierce face.

„I prefer to question Lady Cala first. She can tell us a lot about Shadow Weaver, thanks to which we will learn something about her plans, which will make it easier for us to catch the Dark Sorcerer in a lie." she explained to her friend.

„As long as she wants to talk to us, we won't do anything to her if she chooses to remain silent.” Adora said, crossing her arms over her chest.

„One did not force her, the other will have no qualms about it” Catra said through gritted teeth. Seeing the pure hatred in her friend's eyes, she felt uneasy.

„It seems to me that Lady Cala has no love for Shadow Weaver, and she likes to brag even more than Horde Prime although it's hard to imagine that this is possible.„ She murmured and closed her eyes, trying to gather her thoughts, and then stretched out her hands to her friends about Brother Blade and asked.

„Is everyone ready?” and when everyone nodded yes, she moved them to the place where they kept the monster.

As soon as they got there, they heard the humming of a quiet melody. It was quite pleasant to the ears, and she would have gladly stopped to listen to it if she had not been aware of who the creature was who was humming it. Lady Cala was kneeling with her legs crossed. She was now in Human form, her dress partially torn, her hair disheveled, hanging loosely over her shoulders and chest. Her eyes were closed and her face was decorated with a dreamy smile. She seemed so beautiful and innocent. And then she started singing.

Mother reborn

To bring the Thorn

Mother revived

To fulfill destiny.

Mortal seed

Beaded with despair

Planted in the soil of pain

It will give an abundant harvest.

This is not your war

But it is you who will perish

Mere tools unaware

That their souls are at stake

Everything started

Before the beginning of time

And it will last

Until the very end

A wonderful Creator

In Their wickedness

They guided my Fate

That I would come to you

They made me a gift

Very generous indeed

Which delight and despair

I'll bring it to you!

And then Lady Cala opened her eyes.

„Hello, Glimmer. Hello Adora and Catra! How nice to see you! Sorry I didn't say hello right away, but I was inspired! Did you like my song? Artistic skills are an extremely important element of classical education!" she giggled.

„Well, at least you'll have a way to while away your time in your cell, because you won't be leaving it anytime soon. Our grandchildren will be the next ones you talk to if you don't bother to give satisfactory answers." Catra said, smiling predatorily.

„I have time, Catra. However, one thing intrigues me!„ She stood up and walked closer to the force field and rested her head on her shoulder and said to her with a concerned face. "I have a feeling that your mother would be unhappy with the conditions in which you are imprisoning me, although I'm not sure whether she would be more angry that I don't have a four-poster bed here or that I'm not coughing up pieces of my lungs... She's a very complicated woman?" she shook her head with concern.

Hearing the Aristocrat's words, she felt a wave of anger wash over her. She jumped to the energy barrier and, clenching her fists, shouted.

„How dare you mention it! You…" she let out a string of insults so vicious that even Catra's ears fell flat, and Brother Blade looked at her in shock.

„Ouch! What terrible language! Who would have expected such a vocabulary from such a noble lady! Is this how your parents raised you?" she asked, clicking her tongue a few times. She wanted to hit her, but Adora put a hand on her shoulder.

“Do not listen to her. She wants to provoke you.” Her friend said, and then turned to the aristocrat. “Why did you come here? Someone ordered you to kill me?” she pierced Lady Cala with a sharp look. The Carurystal woman sighed heavily and sat down.

„Unfortunately, I was forbidden to harm you. Yesterday's events were entirely my initiative. I found a trick in a deal my Master made with Shadow Weaver. Unfortunately, I'm afraid that was playing too much with his will anyway. – she said and smiled sadly, as if she had to tell them tragic news.

„But why did you want to do it? We've never met before, you have no reason to hate me. – Adora said with absolutely no understanding in her voice.

„ I had no reason to kill you? You don't understand anything!” Lady Cala gritted her teeth in a furious grimace. “You stupid idiot and your lover, a feral animal, have ruined my existence!”

All three of them stared at Lady Cala in disbelief, so ridiculous were her accusations.

„How were we supposed to do anything to you?” Catra growled. “You made the choice. Since you arrived, no one has done anything bad to you, although we had reasons not to trust you, we tried not to let you feel it.”

Then La dyCala burst out laughing. She was so amused that tears ran down her cheeks.

„How narrow minded you are! Do you really think you understand what's at stake? You are not players, not even pawns! But luckily you have me here! Let me explain everything here in a way that even your happily ignorant minds can understand the truth!” Lady Cala said and started walking around her cell with her hands behind her back. “It all started when a sorceress found the Mirror. It was a very unusual mirror. It contained the Truth about the world. The sorceress was a bitter woman until now. She had great knowledge, or so she thought, but not the power she dreamed of.

She faced the prospect of spending a very long life as a mere teacher, with all dreams of greatness fading away like mist in the sunlight. The sorceress had no intention of accepting her fate. So she decided to listen to the whispers of the mirror. It told of wonderful secrets that neither the members of Mystacor's council nor any of the princesses they knew had ever heard of them. However, as she gained knowledge, her contempt for the ignorance of the inhabitants of this planet, especially those who were given great power by virtue of birth, grew. Hunger grew along with the contempt. Hunger for power. A mirror could remedy that. It told her about a ritual that gave her what she had always wanted. However, it was extremely dangerous, but fortunately the mirror knew a way to limit the danger. At first, the sorceress wasn't sure, she hesitated whether to use the mirror. But then the Horde arrived, and the sorceress took it as a sign from fate...

„Yes, yes ... Even we ignorant people know this story." Catra said, smiling contemptuously.

Lady Cala bowed to her and said.

„I was taught that a good story requires a foundation, but since you lack patience, I will skip some of the more boring parts." she cleared her throat and continued. "As you probably remember, the ritual did not go quite as planned by our dear sorceress. However, you certainly do not know who the creature that came at her call was. For it was the Devourer of Light, one of the thousand of thousands Masks of the Great Outer God Nyarlathotep! Creeping Chaos. Emissary of the Outer Gods. Their soul. The personification and patron of free will."

Out of the corner of her eye, she saw that both Adora and Catra began to listen more closely to the monstrous aristocrat's story when the name Nyarlathotep was mentioned, as if they had heard of him before.

„You see, my dear, the universe is old, older than you can imagine. In the Darkness Between the Stars There are beings who

remember the beginnings of this universe and are even older than it. However, their minds are so alien from yours that even trying to understand what they are would shatter your self like a sheet of glass. They don't care about mortal lives either, any more than any of you care about insects, you only notice them when they start to irritate you and then you crush them with your sole. However, there is one exception. Nyarlathotep loves mortals in each of Their masks. It is a difficult and demanding love, rather like the love that a gardener gives to the flowers in his garden. Proper care sometimes requires pruning or pulling out plants that are growing inappropriately, but also protects them from bad weather and pests. It may seem objectifying to you, but it is still much more than some people received from their mothers." she looked pointedly at Catra , who clenched her jaw angrily, and Melog growled, turning red. "Horde Prime irritated him. The Creeping Chaos did not care about the deaths of millions. After all, dying is the only thing mortals can do well, although even in this aspect you can disappoint, as one sorceress proved. However, the destruction that Horde Prime wreaked was unacceptable. Destroying entire civilizations was an unimaginable waste of potential. Horde Prime was like a unruly, stupid brat who uprooted plants in his garden and trampled on young shoots." When Lady Cala began to talk about Horde Prime, Brother Blade began to look at the noblewoman in disbelief. Horde Prime has been referred to by many different terms, but never as a brat. „The Great Outer God began to devise countless schemes to punish this pompous idiot... However, significant complications occurred. When they touched the sorceress's mind, they learned everything she knew, even her deepest secrets, which she was not even aware of. What they heard disturbed them. For They remembered the terrible weapons the First Ones had created. Giving her to Horde Prime was like giving a spoiled child a can of gasoline and matches. Everything he had cherished over many eons could be lost because of this idiot's childish malice. So They made another plan, a great plan, because its key element was to be me." she bowed courtly to them and continued. "I was made! It cost an unimaginable amount of resources and effort, but I assure you it was worth it!" she performed a pirouette to present herself in all

her glory. “I was created for one purpose only, to teach Horde Prime humility . For this purpose, I was to go to Etheria and become a character from the legends that this sorceress loved so much, i.e. She-Ra . Unfortunately, as you can guess, there was one obstacle in the way of fulfilling this plan. No one, not even Nyarlathotep, was able to determine Etheri's location... But fortunately, the great outer God had a certain sorceress there, whom he marked with a ritual that made it necessary for her to contact them, otherwise she would face a terrible and torturous death. But the cunning witch found a way to cheat fate, even if it was so degrading. She never made contact with the Creeping Chaos after that, perhaps out of scruples, but I personally believe she was simply too cowardly to face Nyarlathotep again. But the Creeping Chaos has countless minions who possess immeasurable resources. A large research center and observatory was built on the planet Nocturnus, controlled by a certain Doctor Sidonius.” she looked at Catra, who pricked up her ears. “I think you know where this is going. After some time, it was possible to determine Etheria's location, so the construction of a teleportation machine was started , which would in the future transfer one miracle child to a planet cut off from the rest of the universe. However, it was difficult, years passed, the wonderful creature that I am appeared in the world, and scientists still did not find Etheria. But then something was detected, a portal opening straight from where Etheria was. We even managed to locate the place from which the gate was opened. However, the chief arch-blasphemer , leader of the cultists who owned the facility, forbade the Doctor from sending the divine child, despite the ancient scientist's strong assurances that the object sent to Etheria would be safe. It was decided to test the device on something much less valuable, something that was bought for pennies and no one cared about it. So they put a kid who absolutely no one wanted into an applesauce box and pulled a lever.„ Lady Cala smiled venomously at Catra, who stood hunched as if a heavy weight was pressing down on her. Adora walked over to her wife to hug her and she teleported next to her and did the same. She understood how difficult it must have been for her friend. The words of this monstrous creature confirmed everything Shadow had been

saying all these years in the horde. She looked at Lady Cala , whose eyes sparkled with cruel joy.

„You are a monster.” she said through clenched teeth, Lady Cala giggled.

„Haven't we already established this? Continuing. Unfortunately, the moment the kid disappeared through the portal, something strange happened Someone from Etheri, a Being called Light Hope, hacked into the facility's systems and caused the portal to explode, killing all the scientists except Dr. Sidonius, killing a vampire is really not easy. Meanwhile, I came to Carurystal, to a family that had the misfortune to have the surname Grayskull. Believe it or not, the founder of the family was simply a pirate. Because of you, I was condemned to a boring life, devoid of purpose and meaning.” she looked at them with hatred. But then Catra burst out laughing and said.

„You blame a helpless child for being condemned to become a child soldier instead of you while you lived in luxury? Do you hear yourself, how stupid you are?” The cat girl could barely contain her bitter mirth. Lady Cala just smiled wider. However, she mentioned something the Aristocrat had talked about earlier and asked.

„What deal were you talking about?

Lady Cala looked at her gently and tilted her head as if considering an answer.

„Agreement between Shadow Weaver and Nyarlathotep. It is because of her that you have the honor of being in my distinguished company!” she bowed to them once again.

„Will you tell us what its conditions were?” She asked the Aristocrat, not expecting that she would give them an answer, this time the Aristocrat surprised her. She stared at them for a moment, now with complete seriousness, until she finally said.

„To save the universe.”

They looked at her confused.

„Save the universe in what sense? After all, Horde Prime has been annihilated!” she exclaimed, but the aristocrat laughed.

„Horde Prime was a bit of a nuisance, but to immediately become a threat? Oh no! There are already powers in the galaxy that could deal with him, in the case of a Star Empire even without effort. You know, they're the funny guys who hosted your mother. No, Horde Prime's time has passed. I'm talking about someone completely different...„ She looked at Adora . “I'm talking about your compatriots, Princess of Power.”

„But they were destroyed by Horde Prime ! He told me about it himself!” Adora exclaimed, looking confused.

„Oh, you really are so gullible. He was talking a lot of nonsense, if even some of it was true... The Primes were very powerful... they are extremely powerful... Horde Prime had no chance against them... Even if he was able to stand up to his masters.”

She opened her eyes wide.

„Does this mean that the First Ones created Horde Prime?” she asked, she wasn't even surprised by this news. That explained a lot.

„Yes... At least partially. Unfortunately, I don't know everything, only what has been deemed appropriate to reveal to me. The First Ones waged war, a war against many adversaries, who together began to triumph over your Adora's compatriots. That's why they created the Heart of Etheria. But they weren't as stupid as you might think. They didn't put everything on one card. They decided to create an army, powerful, even invincible and, most importantly, absolutely devoted to their orders. The heart seemed to have more potential, although it wasn't initially intended to be a doomsday weapon, but eventually it became one, further proof that when you give mortals great power, they only have enough imagination to cause a really big explosion. The First Ones were

few in number, and, having learned from the experiences of one of the races they had once defeated, they did not want to entrust their fate to the AI. But they discovered something, an ancient artifact with an entire pocket dimension. There was a creature living there that offered its help. With her help, a powerful clone army was created in a hidden sector... However, before it was ready, a rebellion organized by Mara broke out. It covered the entire Empire, especially the colonies that suffered most from the capital's imperialist ambitions. After losing Etheria, everything fell apart. The Empire fell and its capital, Eternia, hid in an inaccessible dimension. The rebels were forgiven for the sins of their former rulers. However, they were preparing vengeance. The Great Army was waiting in hiding, slowly conquering distant worlds and growing in strength. The being they released from the Artifact took over this army. However, the First Ones deceived their ally. They tore apart his mind, melted it down and forged it into something new. He became Horde Prime, the overseer of the Horde. He was ordered to exact revenge on his former enemies and traitors, but their plans were much more ambitious, as he was to rid the galaxy of intelligent life. He was doing quite well, but he was imperfect." Lady Cala smiled at Brother Blade. "His nature as a demented megalomaniac. Instead of being a tool to cleanse the galaxy, he began building an empire. Not very well functioning, which he was slowly destroying anyway, but it was still a violation of his orders. He fulfilled his mission slower and slower. However, its former rulers were dissatisfied, so they decided to introduce a new plan. I'm not sure what happened next, because obviously we have no contact with the First Ones, but first they decided to use a simpler method. So they sent a certain child to Etheria. I guess we now know what happened next." The aristocrat looked at Adora, smiling contemptuously.

„So everything is fine. After all, Adora ruined their plans! We are safe now!„ she said with hope in her voice. But when Lady Cala smiled broadly at her, she realized that she was very wrong.

„No, you're not. For the First Ones have Many Servants. Including a Hunger That Cannot Be Satiated. And believe me, they won't hesitate to use it. For you have destroyed not one, but two of

their toys. He will not forget this for you. And after all, they have a Galaxy to cleanse.” said the monster with a beautiful face and sat down cross-legged, resting his head on his hand. There was silence. She felt as if the entire room had become icy cold. She looked at her friends. Catra flattened her ears, and Melog curled up at her companion's feet. Adora stood firm, staring at the Aristocrat, but she could see that the princess of power was trembling internally. She herself… Well, she was absolutely terrified. But she pulled herself together.

„What proof do we have that what you say is true?” she said, trying to sound unfazed. Lady Cala laughed and said.

„I have absolutely none. I don't know if everything I told you is just a lie. After all, what are we all, even me, just specks in the endless darkness? But do you dare to take the risk? Will you sacrifice the lives of the inhabitants of Etheria and other worlds because you consider my behavior inconsistent with your moral standards? It's a matter of your conscience, luckily I don't have one.”

Catra, however, grinned menacingly.

„So that's what this whole speech was for? So you can scare us into releasing you! You are a faithful disciple of Shadow Weaver. Girls! Let's get out of here! We can handle it ourselves!” she looked at them and took a step as if she was going to leave. Lady Cala snorted contemptuously and stood up.

„Will you be able to handle it? So who? I was once read a fairy tale about the Princess Of Nothingness. A princess who, deprived of her kingdom and homeland, wanders around the courts, counting on support. I hope that the teachers who read it to me wanted me to learn humility... Personally, I think I'm too humble... I wonder which of you could be called the Princess of Nothingness. Are you Adora?” she looked at the Princess of Power. “You have renounced your nation... You have twice betrayed those you fought for... You have no one and nothing. The only thing that makes you valuable is the power you received through some sick

joke of fate. But this power can leave you at any moment, or, what would be much funnier, consume you. Or Maybe you.” she looked at Catra . “A kitten abandoned so many times… Unwanted… It's probably occurred to you more than once that it's your fault. That others saw what you were like deep inside. That you're not good enough. That you are a disappointment. Now you have turned out to be some kind of princess, inheritor of a fallen kingdom, heiress of a lost throne. But how long will your father, your friends and your wife be there for you when you become the same? It was easy now to keep her true self in check, but when times get tough, and believe me they do, won't the real Catra reveal her true self to the world again? What about your rights, Queen Glimmer?” she looked her straight in the eyes. “Ruler of a Kingdom built on the graves of the murdered… I wonder if your mother knew the truth that I learned yesterday…”

„What truth are you talking about?„ she asked, looking confused at Lady Cala .

„The truth about the fate of the true inhabitants of Etheria.” When she said this, Catra lowered her head and Melog turned blue. “Oh, you already know! Who would have thought that you would be willing to share the truth you discovered with your wife and friend?”

„What is she talking about?” she asked Catra , who started talking in a low voice.

„Then, in the underground city, we came across a painting. It depicted the previous She”Ra. She... belonged to a race that no longer exists...„ she said quietly, and Lady Cala nodded.

„In fact, the First Ones exterminated the original inhabitants to steal She-Ra's power, and then brought in the workers, whose descendants now inhabit Etheria. You rule a kingdom that is not your own, Dear Glimmer... Just like you, Adora , you rule the power that your ancestors stole from the true inhabitants of the planet...

Then there was silence. She knew that most of what Lady Cala said wasn't true. She wanted to hurt them, sow seeds of doubt in their souls. She could only hope that nothing would sprout. But that last one… It completely undermined the way they saw themselves… The way she saw herself. Who was she then... Did they have the right to call themselves inhabitants of Etheria ? However, she decided that she would not give this woman the satisfaction.

„You are the Princess Of Nothingness.” she said firmly, not taking her eyes off the monster with a beautiful face.

„What? „ asked the surprised Aristocrat.”

„You have power, I cannot deny that to you, but it comes from the being from whom you come. Everything you have was given to you by your master and can be taken away by him at any time. You are just his tool, used to fulfill the purpose for which you were created. However, you have nothing behind it . No one who would care about you, who would worry about you. All you have is the void where others have their hearts.”

Lady Cala stared at her speechless, then growled.

„I swear by the power in my veins that I will take your planet away from you and turn the lives of its inhabitants into a nightmare.”

„Try it.„ she said quietly and, taking her friend and Brother Blade's hands, she teleported to her chambers, leaving the furious monster to pound its fists into the force field.

Chapter End Notes

I did this chapter quickly. And who do you think is the Princess of Nothingness?

Unforgiven

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She woke up.

For a brief moment she thought that she was once again in captivity to Queen Angela, that the war was still going on, that Catra and Adora were on opposite sides, that the last few years had been just a dream... And then she touched her face and noticed that she was not wearing a mask She closed her eyes. She felt a pounding pain in her head. She examined her head, it turned out that her wound was bandaged, the inhabitants of Etheria cared even for their enemies. She smiled bitterly and washed herself in the sink. She removed the holographic mask and set it aside. While washing herself, she saw another reflection in the mirror instead of her own. She didn't feel ashamed, even though she was half”naked, nor did she look back, because she knew that a person who contacts someone through a mirror image does not intend to spy on others in negligee, although few would find her body attractive... Or maybe they did? It doesn't matter now. The man on the other side wore SLR glasses and a top hat. He had fair, even pale skin and dark hair, and his features resembled those of a bird. She didn't recognize him, nor did he trust him, but at least he wasn't the certain Horned Saihe she had also met in the mirror so many years ago. It was from him that her journey that led her here began.

„Good afternoon Miss Daisy or I guess Shadow Weaver... The latter name suits you much better.” he said and bowed politely, although humbly.

„Yes, of all the names I've had, this one suits me best. However, you know my identity, but I don't know yours. That's a shameful imbalance, don't you think?” she asked, raising an eyebrow. At least it was a polite conversation, she couldn't hope for more like it in the near future.

„Ah, I'm so sorry. My manners have deteriorated a bit over the last few decades, the result of spending too much time in the company of bandits and other people of questionable origin. I am Doctor Sidonius...„ he replied to her, changing his accent several times

„ Ah yes, the scholar who condemned an innocent child to me.” she said darkly, feeling a sudden surge of hatred towards both the scientist and herself.

„Oh, dear sorceress, the way you treated her is only your fault.” he laughed mockingly. She nodded.

„You're right, but testing a teleportation device on a defenseless child is undoubtedly a monstrosity.”

He shrugged and said with mild amusement in his voice.

„I am a vampire, which means for many people one of the worst monsters. Isn't it part of my nature to do atrocities?”

She snorted with anger and contempt.

„I don't feel like playing sophistry. You certainly didn't come here to peek at the scarred elf. If you say that's what you came for, I'll have every right to laugh contemptuously.”

He bowed apologetically and said.

„Well, yes, both of us have limited time, although yours is definitely more limited than mine. I came to pay tribute to our mutual friends.”

„Which one of them, because I have the impression that we have surprisingly many of them. Catra and her sister, friends Eti, Bina and Lady Ka... I suspect Arkan-tar is among them too. A surprising number of people for two who are just now meet” she said with a bit of venom in her voice. Not enough to kill, but enough for the toxins to enter the blood.

„We have even more. For I travel with Archduke Adamson and Prince Zed.” he said, and this time she looked at him with surprise.

„Archduke Adamson and Zed are working with you?” she asked, quickly analyzing the implications of what she had just learned. She could imagine reasons why someone like the Archduke would want to work with someone like this vampire, and although everything she could think of had very unpleasant implications, but the ancient Automaton didn't strike her as the type of person interested in being friends with someone like Doctor Sidonius. Prince Zed was a cunning fox who usually knew more than others, but she couldn't see him as more than a gossip, or at most an information broker.

„Kane and I have known each other for a very long time, and Prince Zed is a really interesting person.” said the Vampire with a Carurystal Accent. Something about Sidonius' words disturbed her greatly.

„For a long time? Is that what you mean?” she said slowly.

„Since the time of the Lost Golarion, it seems... The memories of that period are very distant, but I still remember them better than anything that happened during the Gap. Yes, the Archduke is really that old, although for consolation I will tell you that not only you have been deceived, but also all the inhabitants of his planet. It's a matter of an artifact, a very long story for which we neither have time nor inclination.”

„So why are you disturbing my peace? Are you willing to trade what I know in exchange for helping to free Me? Or do you just

want to chat? I don't drink anymore, even though I want to, but I'm sure the guards will bring me tea whenever I ask for it. The people of Etheria are extremely kind to their captives.” she said, not hiding the anger in her voice. She had some really difficult times ahead of her and needed time to prepare for the meeting with Catra and Adora... And Glimmer...

Dr. Sidonius nodded as if he accepted her arguments and said.

„I came here to warn you, my dear Shadow Weaver!” exclaimed Doctor Sidonus in a theatrical tone.

„I was at this performance during the Winter Festival when I was visiting a school located on Cala’s land.” she said in a grave tone. This Vampire was a surprisingly frivolous person for someone who had such a good reputation.

„This is my daughter's favorite story, I have read it to her so many times that I know it by heart. Moreover, it perfectly reflects the situation you find yourself in.” said the undead scholar. She rolled her eyes. She appreciated good stories and interesting metaphors, but only when the situation fit, and this one definitely didn't fit.

„Just say what you have to say and leave me the damnedest alone.” she said with resignation.

„Today you will be visited by three ghosts! The Ghost of the Vile Past, the Ghost of the Grim Present, and the Ghost of the Lost Future. But don't worry, because later the rescue will come!” he exclaimed, making a face like from a street theater and laughing. She thought for a moment. The first ghost was definitely Catra and Adora... The other two were a much bigger mystery. Lost Future… she suspected who it could be. This possibility was also painful, but it was the pain she deserved. But the Grim Present? She had some guesses, but nothing more. So she decided to see what the Vampire would talk if he asked directly.

„Lady Cala somehow managed to justify her reason for visiting me, or does she care what others think?

The undead scholar laughed and said.

„Unfortunately, your new and noble protégé decided to take off the mask of a noble lady and revealed her true face to the inhabitants of Etheria, and sadly they did not like it very much. Well, apparently she was too flamboyant."

„I suspect it's because she tried to murder someone, am I wrong? „ she said in a resigned tone. This made it all extremely complicated... Their orders from the Creeping Chaos were clear, though in their graciousness they had given them a lot of leeway in interpreting them, but currently they were both grounded and she had no idea how much patience the Great Outer God had left. Although they was a being older than the stars, they existed in the space-time of ordinary mortals. the had to take the passage of time into account. And they lost too much of it with their arrogant pride. It was difficult to count on the understanding of a creature that was the embodiment of evil and chaos. She had to think of something, and fast, or the consequences might be unimaginable, and not just because of Nyarlathotep's Wrath. For she knew that the First Ones were waiting to exact revenge on the those who were so dear to her.

„But how do you know all this, dear doctor? Have you gained prophetic abilities in exchange for losing your beating heart?" she asked sarcastically.

„Oh, nothing like that!" the Vampire laughed, genuinely amused. "These are rather the skills of a hacker and spy drone controller." she had a hard time stopping herself from looking around the room. "You can acquire a lot of different skills during such a long life, unless you are extremely lazy. However, I have to end this fascinating discussion, but someone may come here soon and I don't want to reveal my presence here. I guess you won't report me either, because I think you'd rather have me as a friend, right?" he asked and without waiting for her answer he disappeared. She sighed. So she was left alone. So she finished washing and changed the dressing and made a bandage from a piece of bedclothes. She knew she should ask the guards to bring

her some bandages, but she couldn't bring herself to call someone from the castle. She knew it was stupid, but she felt that as long as none of the guards came in, she would remain free... But had she been free in the last thirty years? First she served Hordak, constantly trying to please him, and now her master was Nyarlathotep, who literally possessed her soul. In fact, during the months she was held captive, Glimmer was more free than she was in Castle Grayskull. Even during the occupation, it enjoyed more freedom than in the previous decades. She doubted whether the Queen of Etheria would be so understanding towards her this time. After all, she had broken her trust last time. Besides, Catra was now the Grand Marshal... The thought of facing her terrified her more than the prospect of facing the Wrath of the Great Outer God. She wasn't afraid that her former protégé would do something to her. Adora and Glimmer wouldn't let her anyway... But first of all, it wasn't that same Catra who pulled that lever. This girl has already learned what love and security are... Of course, her return may destroy everything and scratch old wounds. The girl harmed herself by imprisoning her... No, she shouldn't blame her for her mistakes. In the end, she allowed herself to be captured, she didn't take proper precautions, forgetting that her unwanted daughter could recognize her even in a Holographic mask.

She wasn't sure what Lady Cala might have done to get her imprisoned, but it must have been something terrible. If she had revealed her true nature to them, it would probably not be easy for her to gain their trust... Though that might have been too far-fetched. The only thing she could count on from Catra and the others was a chance to be heard... But perhaps the fact that Lady Cala revealed her true nature could prove to be auspicious for her. After all, there was no longer a ban on mentioning who she actually worked for, since Lady Cala told who, or rather what, she was... Maybe if she talked about how great a threat could come to Etheria, and even threaten the whole of Etheria. To prevent it, everyone will have to join forces, not only the inhabitants of this planet, or even Horde Prime's Empire, but everyone, perhaps all beings in the Galaxy... But what were the chances that she would

be able to convince Glimmer and everyone else? She will be very lucky if she manages to make herself heard. As she looked at it now, the whole thing seemed more and more absurd. What was she thinking? She was just an ugly, bitter woman who never believed in anything or loved anyone... She once again imagined that she would be a hero, that she would stand in the way of empires, even though she was just a blade of grass in front of a hurricane. She laughed loudly at her own Arrogance until one of the guards came in to see if she was okay, but when she looked at him, he let out a strangled scream and ran out. Yep, she forgot to put on the holographic mask she took off while washing. Now she decided not to wear it. Throughout her stay in the Fright Zone, she hid her face as if to deny what she had done. As if, along with the ugliness of her face, she was trying to hide the ugliness of her soul. Never again. If she was to accept her villainy, she could no longer hide behind a mask. Let those she hurt have the opportunity to look her in the face.

She must have fallen asleep for a while as she lay on that soft bed.. This hasn't happened to her in decades, at least when she was sober. She heard footsteps, the clatter of heavy soldiers' boots, reminding her of all those years she spent in the Fright Zone. Someone stopped in front of the door and gave a few instructions to the guards, and then the door opened and a person she had not expected entered. She saw Lord Admiral Felix Antares himself, along with Lady Ka and that terrible wolf monster. The three of them entered the chamber and the woman in the half-mask unfolded a small device.

„This really useful invention will provide us with a bit of discretion, which is so important when talking to people like us.” Antares stated in a very polite tone. Lady Ka set up the strange contraption for a few moments, then looked at it and grimaced.

„You're so ugly. Even uglier than everyone says.” The Lord Admiral's left hand giggled.

„At least I don't hide my ugly face behind a mask anymore. “ she drawled, staring at the wicked woman, who giggled again in

response and said.

„If you saw what I hide behind the mask, you would be quite surprised.”

But then the Lord Admiral signaled for Lady Ka to be silent and walked up to the magical barrier and said.

„We can finally meet face to face. I must admit that I didn't think Miss Daisy would hide such an interesting secret. Anyway, I feel honored to meet you in person.” he bowed to her respectfully.

„I can't say the same about myself. When I was with your second daughter, I heard a little about you. I wonder how Catra will react when I tell her who her father is.” she said, summoning her proudest tone, but the Lord Adimral smiled slightly and said.

„If she believes you... But I didn't come here to discuss my past. I'm here to thank you.”

„For what?” she asked, honestly surprised.

„For everything you did to make my daughter who she is. You made me proud of her. Yes, you had to be harsh with her, but after all, shouldn't the Scepter of a Monarch be forged in the fire of suffering? You saved me a lot of problems by taking on the burden of hardening her soul. I somewhat regret that we meet under such circumstances, because I cannot in any way show you the gratitude that you have worked hard for all these years to make her a worthy member of House Antares.

She stared at the Lord Admiral for a moment, wondering if she had understood his words correctly. This person was grateful to her for the way she treated his daughter? For years of torment and humiliation just because she was in a bad mood. She took it out on Catra because another experiment failed, because Hordak demanded successes that she couldn't give him, because she couldn't stand her self-hatred. Sometimes she told herself that she was doing all this for the good of her ward, although deep in her black heart she knew that she was just doing something mean. It

didn't make Catra strong... It was Catra who found the strength within herself to not break despite years of torment. First she found it in anger and hatred, and then in Love for Adora and friendship. This individual didn't understand it... But what could she expect from an individual who dropped nuclear warheads on his own nation?

„You know what, Antares? I used to believe that Lady Cala was a wicked and vile creature, but I came to the conclusion that I couldn't blame her for anything, after all, she was born a monster, I can't expect the same from her as I do from mortals... Horde Prime was undoubtedly evil, but If what I heard from the Crawling Chaos was true, then even he was merely a victim... At least to some extent. I am vile and evil to the core, but I am fully aware of my wickedness. But you, Lord Admiral Antares, are a bastard, a miserable wretch in an expensive uniform who is so blind that he cannot even see the ugliness of his own soul. You can wear a mask of righteousness now, but believe me, all masks eventually fall, I know that, and when Catra sees your true colors, she will disown you and you will end up in a place like me now, if you are lucky.”

Antares looked at her for a moment. She couldn't read what he was thinking, but she hoped she had put a finger in his inflated ego. He finally said, his voice almost as polite as before. It almost made a big difference.

„Well, on the other hand, you shed a lot of my family's blood, though mostly symbolically. Despite all my gratitude to you, such an offense must be met with a just punishment. It's nothing personal, I assure you. And thank you for the warning, sometimes in my arrogance I forget that I make mistakes.„ and he moved to leave, but before he left the room, she called to him.

„You say you value your blood so much... I respect that, so I'll share some news with you. Ask Lady Ka what happened to your other daughter's left hand... Why does she have to wear a glove. – she said, smiling triumphantly. The Lord Admiral looked at Lady Ka, a blue light flashing in his one living eye.

„What is she talking about... „ Antares said in a voice that froze even her black heart. Lady Ka turned pale and began to slowly back away.

„She started it... she scratched my face to the bone, so I punished her. I ordered her to remove all the claws on her left hand. This is what discipline looked like in our company, do you understand?” she said in a pleading tone.

„I see.” said the Lord Admiral, grabbing the hilt of his saber and cutting off Lady Ka's fingers in one fluid movement. The woman let out a loud scream and grabbed her injured hand. However, the guards didn't run in, so apparently the device was working properly and no one heard anything. She herself was in a bit of shock, the sudden brutality of such a composed man as the Lord Admiral even astonished her, but she also felt vindictive satisfaction in seeing Lady Ka receive her well-deserved punishment.

„Lord Admiral... I only followed the Regulations... These were the penalties we had in the Company, this is how Jantar treated us.” Lady Ka said. There was no blood flowing from the wound, and the edges of the Lord Admiral's sword blade glowed red, so the wound was definitely cauterized. However, she guessed that the pain must have been terrible, but the clone woman remained conscious and even started dressing the wound. She may have been a crazy psychopath, but in all fairness she was tough.

„You did it not out of concern for my daughter's upbringing, but out of a desire to vent your anger. Normally I would let you two resolve this dispute between you two, but you have permanently crippled her. Perhaps what you did has created a rift between us and that's why he refuses to join me at all costs. Perhaps I shouldn't have let Jantar take care of her upbringing. In his obsessive pursuit of perfection, he tried to suppress her natural temperament, which was so important to the ruler. I don't blame you, your father was a very toxic man, but you still had to be punished somehow. It's nothing serious, eventually you will grow new ones and transplant them, or implant a cybernetic

replacement. I assure you that implants are much better than real organs... And believe me, if I didn't respect you so much, you would be punished much more severely for what you did. " he said, while the wolf-like beast devoured the severed fingers. Lady. Ka nodded, then looked at her and smiled a very nasty smile. Well, whatever this woman could do to her was nothing compared to the punishment Nyarlathotep could inflict on her... Or her own conscience...

„ Are you sure you're ready for this?" Glimmer asked her in a gentle voice, and she answered her with a dark smile.

„I won't be any more ready." she replied evasively. She wasn't really ready. Previously, she was aware that Shadow Weaver was alive, but until now it was a distant specter, something you don't think about every day, but you know that you will have to face it. A bit like being aware of your own mortality. Now she also felt that a part of her had died. The part that had been joyful during the past five years... She was afraid she would never be happy again.

You can't let yourself be consumed by such dark thoughts. Then she will win. she thought, gritting her teeth.

„Are you sure everything's okay?" Glimmer asked, looking at her with concern, but this only irritated her.

„And how can it be when the woman who has been abusing me for almost my entire life and tried to separate me from my beloved comes back from the dead, shows up at my wedding and tries to kill one of my friends!„ she growled at Glimmer, causing her to back away and Melog turning red. She closed her eyes and said.

„I'm sorry, Glimmer. I just don't want to see her, but I know that if I don't look her in the eyes now, I won't find peace."

Her wife embraced her and said in a tender tone.

„Darling, it's hard for all of us because she hurt us all, but you especially badly. I'm just wondering if you should wait a while after what Lady Cala said.”

„ No, I want to get this all over with and focus on freeing Entrapta and the empress.”

Glimmer nodded and took their hands.

This time she quickly got over the nausea that usually accompanies teleportation. She was sitting on the bed, but as soon as she noticed their presence, she raised her head. Glimmer let out a strangled cry and Adora looked away. Shadow Weaver wasn't wearing her mask now, and everyone could see her disfigured face. It was probably the first time Glimmer had seen her... It wasn't a pleasant sight for those who weren't prepared for it. Even they, who had spent so many years with her, could hardly look at her. Looking at this hag’s face always meant suffering, or at least screaming. Adora instinctively looked away, she felt like it too, but she overcame it, she would look at Shadow Weaver without fear!

„Hi Catra... And Adora and of course Glimmer.„ said the Dark Sorceress, looking at her feet. When she heard her voice, she felt her blood boil in her veins. After everything she had done, after all the countless humiliations and all the suffering she had caused them all, she had the nerve to come back to their wedding after five years and all she had to say to them was hi Catra?... It was as if she had spit in her face.

„You should be dead...„ she drawled, struggling to control her anger. Shadow Weaver looked up at her.

„I said the same thing when I stood before Carsai called the King.” said the Dark Sorceress in a low voice. By voice. She remembered the name, it was in the book Aize had shown her… She remembered the creature in the illustration. What was the name of this book? Thousand of Thousand’s Masks… The same

term was used not long ago by Lady Cala… She was referring to Nyarlathotep…. She smiled at her former tormentor.

„So you read about them in a book... Clever, but you forgot that I also read sometimes... „ She smiled mockingly at Shadow Weaver, but the older woman smiled sadly.

„So you managed to get one copy after all... If I had it, everything would have been different. We would live in a different world.” she said, using the same words Mikah used a few weeks ago. This only fueled her fury.

„Fairy tales and fabrications, I would expect something better thought out from someone who has always prided himself on being smarter than everyone she knows.” she said, trying to imbue every word she spoke with pure contempt. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Adora seem concerned. Her wife approached the dark Sorceress and asked in a firm but calm tone.

„What's the point of all this? Why did you come back here? You had the entire Galaxy to yourself... Do you really hate us so much that you had to come here to take away our joy...”

Shadow Weaver shook her head…

„I don't hate you... I... I was forced to come back here partly because of the agreement I made... But I also did it of my own free will...„ She raised her head and looked them straight in the eyes. “Etheria is in terrible danger…”

„Yes Yes Yes.„ She interrupted in an irritated voice. „Your new ward has already told you everything. You came here to save us all, because we are too stupid and too clumsy and we can't cope on our own, so we have to free you.” She looked condescendingly at the Dark Sorcerer. With each sentence she uttered, her contempt for this woman grew.

„She basically said what Catra says, although I'm guessing the Calamity addition is everything about us.” Glimmer said thoughtfully, glancing at her sideways. „ She was talking about

some Hunger, what did she mean... „ Her friend's voice was filled with concern, as if she believed what Shadow Weaver and her psychopathic minion were saying.

„ The Hunger That Cannot Be Satiated... The Thousand of Thousand's Maws... is a euphemistic term for the Swarm, the greatest Scourge of the Galaxy. You don't have to take my word for it as to how big of a threat it is. Ask anyone outside Horde Prime's Empire, even your Father, and he won't lie to you about this one thing. His ego won't let him do that...„ said the Dark Sorceress, smiling darkly. At the sight, she felt another wave of rage flood her heart.

„I know what you're getting at, you nasty snake! But we can't be manipulated that easily anymore! My father never lied to me, unlike you. He even told me about the Starstone!" it growled at Shadow Weaver.

„What Starstone are you talking about?" Glimmer asked worriedly.

„I'll explain later." she replied without even looking at it. "You want to set me apart from my father, just like you did with Glimmer and Adora, manipulate me just like you did the last time I imprisoned you!"

„Listen to me Catra, your father is different than...." the Dark Sorceress was saying, but she didn't let her continue.

„BE SILENT AND LISTEN TO ME!" She roared at the top of her throat. She took two deep breaths and continued speaking, calming down a bit. – You raised me for most of my life. During this time, you have given me nothing but contempt and pain. You abused me every chance you got. You can't even imagine what it's like to feel like the whole world hates you! I can't count how many nights I cried myself to sleep. How many times did I just want to disappear? If it weren't for Adora... You couldn't even die without showing me that I was trash." she hid her face in her hands. "Have you ever loved me?" she asked, swallowing tears.

Shadow Weaver thought about her answer for a few moments before finally speaking.

„No... Anyway, not like you deserve... I'm sorry... I'm sorry for everything I've done to you."

She stood there not knowing what to do, what to think... What to feel... This apology was worse than if she had slapped her in the face or used dark magic. She took away her hatred... She even took that away from her. Before, it was an important pillar of her being. She was certain of few things in this world until now. One was love for Adora, the other was hatred for Shadow Weaver. Now one of those pillars had fallen, and her whole world was rocking. One more wound inflicted on her by that damned bitch. But she had to pull herself together somehow, at least for a while.

„You will not be forgiven, because what you did to me... to all of us is unforgivable. Just tell me, were you the one who mutilated my sister's hand?" Did you hurt her as much as you hurt me?

Shadow Weaver shook her head.

„I didn't do anything to Eti... I even saved her life several times... To tell you the truth, I've only known her for a little over a month. As for Eti's hand... Ask Lady Ka about it. Also, be sure to ask her where she got her new fingers."

For a moment she felt uneasy, as if the Dark Sorcerer had stirred up some old suspicions, but he dismissed them. She smiled at her former tormentor and said.

„Your charge will rot in the dungeon, choking on its venom, but a different fate awaits you. The Star sisters, especially Halo, will be happy to take care of you." she ignored Glimmer's astonished look. „You know that everyone thought she was crazy until now because she claimed that you were alive... „ she offered her hand to the queens and together with Adora they disappeared in a flash of teleportation.

Everyone recognized Asindesa di Vir as a heroine. After all, she saved Adora, their She-Ra, the One who saved the Galaxy. Everyone looked at her with respect. The previous reserve disappeared completely. Future generations of Hell Knights visiting Etheria will probably be grateful to her for having a good reputation here, of course, as long as they don't ruin it themselves. However, she felt that she had lost her life. The woman she loved so much turned out to be a cultist, a servant of one of the most nefarious forces in the galaxy. The creature she was caring for revealed itself as a monstrous spawn of an Entity worse than demons... And she was actually a traitor or something of that sort. After all, she had developed a close relationship with the enemy, very close even. Revenge was also taken away from her. The monster turned out to be invulnerable to her weapons; she had previously hoped that maybe it was given to her for this purpose. So why did she receive them if not to fight evil that could not be opposed in any other way...

She had no idea what she should do next. She believed that she had to give up command of the contingent of knights, and in the second, much more extensive message, she decided to confess her sins and ask for a quick trial. Until then, she will stay here and pass on hers knowledge of fighting the Great Old Ones to the locals, as the locals have limited knowledge in this field. But now there was one thing left for her to do before she went to sleep.

Due to her newly acquired Hero status, no one stopped her, so she easily reached the room where the prisoner was held. When she asked the guards to let her in, they hesitated for a moment, then parted and let her in... Miss Daisy... Shadow Weaver sat on the bed. She didn't wear a mask, she could see her scarred face, in which she saw so much beauty... Seeing someone enter, the sorceress looked up, and when she recognized her, she cringed.

„Hello, Asindesa Di Vir.” said the prisoner.

„Hello... Shadow Weaver „ she said after a moment's thought. Then they were silent... They were silent for a long time, over a quarter of an hour, until she finally spoke.

„You know, before I met you, I only knew war... Fighting against inhuman beasts that pose a threat to the entire universe. I believed that this was the perfect goal of life... I was not completely happy, but at least somewhat satisfied. Thanks to you, I knew love. A feeling I've never felt before. For a moment, a short moment, I felt that I was the happiest person in the universe... And I lost it... Now I have nothing... Only emptiness in the place of my heart... You shattered me, Shadow Weaver...„ she felt herself crying for the first time since childhood. She took a deep breath and finally asked.

„Have you ever loved me?”

There was silence in the room for a moment, broken by one word.

„Yes”.

This was too much for the Lady of Blades. She turned and went to her chambers to be alone with her despair.

Chapter End Notes

This is probably a breakthrough chapter, I hope I succeeded

Between death and dream

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She adjusted her head, which was resting on her wife's muscular shoulder. She must have been asleep for some time without even realizing it. The events of last night were terrible. She was so close to death, although that wasn't what really scared her, it was the creature they faced. This creature was the embodiment of horror, a denial of everything beautiful, a perversion of the laws of nature... It was so close that... she didn't know what exactly threatened them ... but it was definitely something terrible. However, they will be able to work through it, they just need a little time and love, and there was plenty of the latter. Others had it much worse…

It turned out that there was another monster hiding in Brightmoon Castle, much more insidious than what they were fighting. She remembered what a shock it was for her when it turned out that Flutterina was actually Double Trouble. Only the shapeshifting spy was actually quite a nice person, wonderfully parodying them all, and Lady Cala was... Something else... She wanted to murder, first Adora, and then the children of Spinerella and Netossa. What did they do to her? She could see the cold evil in her eyes as she looked at them as if they were something nasty stuck to her shoe... And that smile... As if all the pain she was about to cause made her happy. There was something so monstrous about her that even Horde Prime seemed less inhuman, more understandable compared to that creature

Additionally, Catra captured Shadow Weaver, the woman who contributed to the death of her wife's mothers. In fact, unlike the others, she didn't feel such dislike towards her. She felt great suffering and anger in that bitter woman, somewhat similar to

what she saw in Catra, only with a different shade, and she also had a knack for plants, although her style of gardening was not to her taste. She didn't know what the Grand Marshal was going to do with her, but nothing good would come of it, especially since Entrapta and the Empress had been kidnapped. The Inventor Princess was sometimes very overwhelming, but she was actually very likable. Scorpia often visited her and had to admit that the inventor could be very Empathetic, as a wedding gift she gave her a self-heating meditation mat, a very practical invention. She and Scorpia would take part in freeing her, she just hoped that Lonnie wouldn't hurt her. After all, she was Catra's friend and they served in the Horde together for a while...

However, it was Frosta who suffered the greatest harm... She was hit by a spell and has been in a coma since yesterday. For now, her condition was stable... But it was unknown when she would wake up, or even if it would happen at all. They could only wait to see what fate would bring. Therefore, he and his wife decided that they would take the first shift to watch over the ice princess. They were tired anyway, so they wouldn't be of much help during the meeting. Next to the girl was also this strange creature from ancient city, which wrapped itself around her as if it were a blanket... He must have loved his companion very much...

Finally, sleep fell upon them, although it was not very deep. She didn't have any dreams, which made her incredibly happy, because what they could bring now wouldn't be nice. While she was half asleep, resting her head on her wife's shoulder, she felt a warm, gentle voice in her head.

„I hope I will be able to help this child somehow."

She opened her half-conscious eyes and saw a tall Insectoid in an emerald robe. The creature looked familiar.

„Hylax ?„ she asked sleepily, and then she felt warm, joyful laughter in her head.

„Oh, that's definitely an exaggeration! I am only a relatively humble servant of the forever queen, although she is often portrayed as one of my species. You probably saw her image somewhere, that's why you are confused.”

„I had a dream once... And you are Shirren ! Just like Ashurk!”she exclaimed, now fully awake.

The insectoid nodded.

„Yes, this is my granddaughter. Her parents asked me to keep an eye on her, but as you've noticed, she's quite... independent and I'm unlikely to protect her from anything she gets herself into.” said the Insectoid in her head. That's when Scorpia woke up. She looked around confused for a moment, and when she saw their new guest, she jumped to her feet, almost saluting. She hadn't given up her soldierly habits, but she loved her for such quirks.

„Oh, I think I fell asleep a bit... Hello... you... uh.” said the former force captain. Shirren laughed amiably again in their minds, making Scorpia flinch slightly.

„I'm Reverend Zimach, he, him, if you're interested. I am a priest of Hylax , the Forever Queen, goddess of friendship and community. I accompany the Fleet, serving with my mystic skills and preaching the glory of living in serene harmony with our fellow people, but I have decided that I will remain on Etheria to explore this planet and meet its inhabitants, and, If they are interested, to impart the teachings of Hylax to them.„ his tone echoing in her head was gentle and cheerful. There was something very nice about this person, she liked him immediately, he didn't irritate her like his granddaughter, although she probably irritated everyone except Entrapta , but she could be just as intense.

„Oh, you're one of those priests they have on Ikarus and Eridani... There aren't many of your kind here... Maybe apart from the Isles of Sorrow or the Singing Jungle... But I believe that the people of Etheria will welcome you warmly and you'll definitely find one

here those who will listen to your mistress's teachings.” she said, smiling friendly. Zimach nodded and spoke into their thoughts.

„Yes, it's a strange place because of its approach to matters of Faith, but in a sense that's why it's so fascinating. I think that we priests can learn a lot from people raised outside our influence. Perhaps this will help us serve both the gods and our faithful better.” Said priest.

„Yeah, I know a lot about service, orders and things like that, and honestly, it's probably better not to speak about it to some people... And this speaking in someone's head may not really appeal to people who were, you know... Under the influence of Horde Prime?” said her wife in a very careful tone. Now she understood how unpleasant it must be for her to hear someone's voice in her head. It reminded her too much of when she was chipped and became part of Horde Prime's hivemind.

„Yes, I understand what you mean.„ This time she felt great sadness in the priest's mental voice. “What Horde Prime did to all of you is an unforgivable act, even dark gods like Asmodeus and Zon-Kuthon would not do such a thing. I must admit that Hylax is also the goddess of collective consciousness, but not one that enslaves and exclude individuality, but allows for the common sharing of emotions and exchange of experiences. It is especially important for me as a priest of the Forever Queen to change the perception of the shared consciousness as something evil and vile... Yes, the mad tyrant has made the work of my brothers and sisters on this planet much more difficult than anywhere else... But in my old age I have become terribly grumpy. I didn't come here to complain about the path I've chosen in life or to talk in vain. I learned that one of the princesses, a girl named Frosta, had fallen victim to Dark Magic and I would like to use my skills as a healer to help her." He finally finished his overly long speech, which echoed in their heads, making her feel like she walked out of the loud concert and into a quiet forest clearing.

„Adora has already used She” Ra's power to heal her, and we also have doctors and healers here.” said Scorpa, looking a bit

distrustfully at the priest, who waved his antennae vigorously and said.

„I don't doubt She-Ra's power or the competence of your doctors and healers, but I have some knowledge that you couldn't know... „ he thought for a moment before adding „I served in the army of the Lord Admiral for some time, but not only that. In the fight against the Swarm, Lady Sorrowflame , and not only her, used dark magic to gain an advantage over this terrible enemy. I understand that sometimes greater necessity forces us to resort to means that are morally questionable, but sometimes it is easy to cross the line... I have seen many soldiers who were struck by death magic and fiendish powers when they found themselves in the crossfire... I had to learn how to help them … Moreover, our lady gave us the power to contact those trapped in a black sleep caused by the powers of darkness."

She shuddered when Zimach mentioned Lady Sorrowflame. This creature made her heart grip with terror. She could imagine that many innocents had crossed her path and suffered a fate similar to those of the unfortunate guards. They exchanged uncertain glances. After a few moments, they nodded together.

„I guess we can try." she said, and the three of them approached the girl's bed. She stayed with Zimach, and she sent Scorpia to inform the head of the hospital about what they were going to do. Frosta was pale, and when she touched her hand, it was cold. However, she could feel a pulse, although it was very faint, and the girl's chest was moving, albeit slightly. Frosta was changed into hospital pajamas, Shogi flattened herself and wrapped herself around her like a blanket. As they approached him, he looked at them with his many eyes.

„Don't worry, we're here to help your lady." she said to the Ice Princess's friend, not sure if he understood her. Apparently so, because she saw concern and an unspoken request in his eyes.

„Such friendship with Shogoth... Amazing!" the priest echoed in her head, and then he placed his chitinous hands on the girl. After

a moment, his jaws chirped.

„Not good... The spell sent her to the Dreamlands, and that in itself is extremely dangerous, but I feel that some other, dark force is reaching for her... I guess no one here has heard of Charon, the rider of Death.” Shirren could hear fear in her voice .

„No... But is there anything you can do to help her?” She asked, also scared.

„Maybe... But you'll have to help me.” said the priest.

„I? Help?” she was completely surprised that Zimach was turning to her for help.

„Yes... We have a lot in common. You are marked by Hylax ... I will explain what that means later, for now do as I tell you.”

She felt as if she had been wandering these halls for days, maybe much longer... perhaps even her whole life. She had trouble remembering her name... who she was... where she came from. It was as if the past was hidden in a thick fog that could not be penetrated. Maybe if she tried a little harder...

Music brought her back to consciousness. Suddenly she heard someone playing the violin. The music wasn't pretty or pleasant, it was downright irritating and even painful, but it was thanks to it that she regained consciousness. She tripped and almost fell. She blinked and looked around. She was in a wide semicircular corridor covered with strange, incredibly complex patterns. The stone it was made of seemed strangely organic and a bit slippery. The corridor in front of her curved sideways and climbed slightly upwards. Strange multi-colored balls were embedded in its walls, glowing brightly. She had the impression that they were looking at her with curiosity. She shivered, but then she felt a tickle on her cheek and heard a bird chirping. She looked back and saw a reddish-brown cloud with many eyes floating next to her.

„Shogi!” she exclaimed with joy at the sight of her shapeshifting friend. Now that she wasn't alone in this strange place, nothing was scary for her!

„Let's go! I don't know where we are, but it's definitely Shadow Weaver's doing!” she exclaimed, because memories were just starting to come back to her. The dark sorceress hit her with a bolt of black power with which she wanted to hit the Entrapta. She must have been sent to some distant place, perhaps to some new headquarters of hers, some Scare Zone, where she was to be imprisoned... Well, if it was a prison, it was a surprisingly poorly guarded one. She shrugged, because it actually suited her, and moved forward together with the cloud-like Shogi.

The corridor wound chaotically in front of her, disturbingly reminding her of some creature's intestines, she hoped they weren't someone's meal... She kept hearing that horrible music, slowly and inexorably getting louder and louder, so she had no choice, that was her only point. indicative of this place. After some time, they reached a longer, more regular and straighter corridor, in one of the walls of which there was a circular opening resembling a window, behind which there was a narrow balcony. Out of pure curiosity, she climbed onto it and looked around, breathing in the frosty, thin air. All around her, she saw towering mountains covered with blue, black, and red ice. The peaks were bent in all directions, twisted like old trees. Some resembled the bones of some unimaginably large animals, or sculptures created by someone with a very strange idea of what is beautiful. The whole place somehow reminded me of that strange town where she found Shogi.

„I don't think we're in Brightmoon anymore ... Or even Etheria” she said anxiously. She shuddered and moved on.

Eventually she found herself in a large, circular room with many circular doors. The largest ones were in front of her and that's where the music came from. Out of curiosity, she looked into the other rooms. One looked like a natural history museum with lots of skeletons, but they looked strangely asymmetrical, as if

someone had put them together from random bones. She had the unpleasant feeling that those skulls were staring at her. She shuddered and looked into another room. It was full of strange plants unlike anything she had ever seen . The bark was strangely leathery, and the needles and leaves looked like bones sticking out of living flesh. When one of the flowers turned towards her and she saw that there was an eye inside it, she ran out screaming.

It was time for her to enter the main room where the music was coming from. She stood on the threshold and looked around carefully. She saw that it was a huge circular concert hall, a place that seemed to generally avoid sharp angles. The stands with seats adapted for people of very different shapes were empty. There was one person playing on stage, wearing a flowing white dress. Her back was turned towards her. Her blue-purple hair flowed in the imperceptible wind. There was something fascinating about this creature. Almost unconsciously, she started walking towards her. When she was almost to the stage, the music stopped and the person playing the violin spoke to her in a soft, feminine voice that seemed to come from all directions.

„Forgive me for not being able to welcome you properly, but I haven't visited the house for a very long time, in fact for aeons, very strange aeons... I guess all my relatives have separated, but this is only a temporary situation. Soon Castle Maledictus will have new inhabitants and laughter and wailing will once again echo through its beautiful halls. You will be one of the first, but not the first... This title belongs to Mr. Norwyn.” the violinist dressed in white pointed up and then she saw a man, a faun, embedded in the rock. His eyes were still moving so he was alive. She screamed in terror and jumped back, but tripped and fell. She looked ahead and saw the violinist is turned towards her. She was floating in the air, her robe flowing like her hair. He was beautiful, even phenomenal. There was something unnatural about her, you could say almost ethereal. In a way, she resembled Queen Angela or She-Ra , because there was something unearthly about her, but her eyes... instead of them, she had two lakes of violet-purple flame, bottomless and as if burning away from her very soul, she felt like they wanted to devour her, devour her mind, her being…

„Come with me... Live with me... Be a guest in my beautiful home.” said the violinist in her omnipresent voice and extended her hand towards her. She screamed and tried to summon her ice, but failed…. She was powerless. She screamed again and started running... But she had no idea where she could hide. This music was her only hope for saving herself from this place. So she ran forward, just to be away from this terrible person. After a while, she saw Shogi floating in front of her, who barked loudly and started motioning for her to follow him. She did so, of course. She had no idea how long she had been running. She felt like her body wasn't getting tired at all, but she didn't think about it because she felt that the woman was behind her. Eventually she reached a large garden, this time looking relatively normal, although she couldn't recognize most of the plants growing there, with a wide stream running through the middle of it. Then she saw the old man. He was dressed in a black coat and wore a wide-brimmed hat. He had a white beard and smiled at her in a friendly manner, but after meeting the previous resident of the castle, she preferred not to approach him. However, he stretched out his hand towards her and said.

„Girl, I know a way that will get us out of here. You just have to get on my boat.” he pointed to the rowing boat next to him, which was standing on the shore. She hesitated for a moment because she felt that the creature was getting closer to her, and that from that woman she was threatened by something much more terrible than anything that old man could do to her... right? But then she heard Shogi start barking happily. She looked in that direction and saw her companion standing at the flower gate, with light shining behind it . She immediately recognized that this was the way out. This time she moved in that direction without hesitation. However, when she was almost at the gate, the old man jumped in .

„You won't escape me!” and rushed towards her. He grabbed her hand and she felt an icy chill penetrate her body. It reached her heart and she let out a strangled cry, but then she touched the gate.

She felt like she was lying in bed and the unpleasant hospital stench was surrounding her, so she opened her eyes. She saw Perfuma leaning over her and an insectoid in emerald robes. As soon as the ruler of Plumeria saw that she had woken up, she hugged her tightly and called out loudly.

„It's so good that you woke up! We managed to drag you to us! I didn't know we would make it, but you are here with us safe and sound!”

„We?” she asked in surprise, and then Isectoid bowed low to her and spoke in her thoughts.

„I am Reverend Zimach, Priest of Hylax called the Forever Queen. However, the entire credit for your awakening lies with Perfume.” he pointed at the flower princess, who blushed upon hearing his words. Then she felt a strong hug and when she looked down, she saw Shogi wrapped tightly around her, flattening himself like a blanket.

„Shogi was there with me too. Thanks to him, I managed to get out of this place!„ She was about to start talking about what happened to her, but then Scorpia entered.

„Oh! You're awake!” A tall woman ran to her and held her tightly in her arms until she lost her breath.

„Honey, give Frosta some time to find her way, and while you're at it, bring some hot chocolate.” Perfuma said and Scorpia saluted.

„That's right, little flower!” and she ran out. While the Scorpion Princess was away, she told Perfuma briefly about what happened to her after the wedding, because both women already knew this part of the story, and then Scorpia came with four cups of hot chocolate. She took one and cooled it with her magic, how nice she was back. After she had had a drink, she told them about where she had been while she slept. Scorpia and Perfuma were looking at her in disbelief throughout the story, they both kept making sounds of disbelief and fear, it was a really great story.

However, the insectoid man kept watching her with his antennae down as if he was worried. She herself was cold, very cold, as if the cold that had taken over her body when the old man touched her did not want to leave her. But she assumed it would eventually go away. She just needs to rest a little.

When she finished, she asked the other princesses to tell her what happened while she was sleeping. They both briefly explained what they were doing, but then said that Catra captured the Shadow Weaver and Lady Cala wanted to kill Adora and then turned into a monster.

„This is amazing, she finally exclaimed, and then Zimach grabbed her hand as if he was taking her pulse.

„Take a deep breath.” he said and she did as he ordered.

„But what do you... „ she wanted to ask, but then she understood. The entire time the two women were talking, she didn't take a single breath…

Chapter End Notes

The violinist will play a role in this story... And as for the Ice Princess... You'll see.

Epiphany and guilt

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She woke up with a terrible headache and immediately stood up and looked around. She was on a spaceship, but it wasn't Merciless . She was lying on a narrow bed that looked like a portable camp bed. She was strapped to it, although not very tightly. There were three people around, two girls and Bina. One of the girls had white hair and strangely deformed ears. She seemed a bit scared and kind of lost. Bina looked almost the same as before, apart from the distinctive vest worn by many adventurer captains who travel through space on their own. This time she exuded an aura of professionalism and smiled cheekily. The third one looked the most unusual. She was similar to Catra, not only because of her feline things, but her facial features also made her similar... She seemed depressed, although she hid it. As soon as they noticed that she had woken up, the white-haired girl breathed a sigh of relief.

„Oh, I was afraid I killed you, I'm glad you're okay... Because you're okay? Don't you have brain damage or something?” she said, speaking in sign language, and the gloves translated her gestures into speech. The cat-like girl ran up to her and lifted her eyelid.

„There doesn't seem to be any damage to her brain, but maybe I should trepan her skull to reduce the intracranial pressure...„ she said in a dull voice. She pushed her hand away violently and said.

„ I'm fine! I mean, nothing new. Please don't make a hole in my head.”

Burgundy-haired woman sighed heavily.

„No one can guarantee a joyful awakening like Eti.„ she said in a sarcastic tone „Well, I guess I didn't tell you everything about myself earlier. As you may have already guessed, I am the captain of this ship and you are currently our captive. It wasn't my idea, but my wards. They want to trade you for She-Ra's broken sword, I'm not sure if that's something to be proud of. But don't worry, you're in no danger here. Even if you tried to escape, we would probably tie you up at worst, so don't worry... I have no idea what Lonnie will do if your captain doesn't want to trade you for a sword, but it doesn't matter at all, because you are mine, or rather our prisoner. I must admit that I absolutely did not suspect Captain Moonshadow of having an Azlantean among her crew members , but it's probably good that something can still surprise me in life. Anyway, welcome aboard.” she explained and unbuckled her seat belt and then went somewhere else. Two girls remained. This feline sat on the floor and limped with her head down. The white-haired woman sat down next to her and hugged her tightly.

„So it's because of you that I ended up here?” she asked uncertainly. Truth be told, she wasn't sure what to do now... The white-haired woman nodded and said.

„I hit you when you bumped into me. I got scared, and when I'm scared, I sometimes do weird things. I'm sorry if it hurts you.” she blushed.

„Nothing happened to m, I've experienced worse things.” she smiled at her. “I'm Tirin, although I think your captain told you that.

„My name is Rosie, this is Eti and... well, she's Catra's sister. I know it's quite strange, but your captain is the queen of Etheria ... Does she know it?” Rosie said, returning her smile.

„I guess so, but I'm not sure how much she remembers. Her memory was taken away... She didn't even know her real name... „ she said, carefully lowering her head and adding. “Apparently

Adora took her sword... That's what the captain says... But I'm not sure how much truth there is in it.”

Rosie shook her head vigorously from side to side.

„This can not be true. Adora is very nice. She couldn't do something so horrible to anyone. You should talk to someone about what happened here... Preferably Kyle ... He's cool and I think he's the one most willing to tell us about everything from the Rebellion.” she said and jumped for joy.

„If so, take us to him.” she said, feeling the girl's enthusiasm starting to rub off on her. Deep down, however, she was worried about what the Captain would do if the truth turned out to be different from her expectations...

Everyone aboard the Merciless celebrated the great spoils, except her. She stared at the remains of the sword. Her sword, which was once taken away from her... and she felt nothing. But it was supposed to be different... When she got him back, she was supposed to regain her memories... past... life... everything... But nothing happened... Nothing at all...

„The captain has a good head on her shoulders.„ Boatswain Kaert exclaimed in a slightly drunk voice. „If we look for buyers, the things we stole will be worth two million credits... And your sword will be worth three times as much if we sell it to the Anacites . As long as you're willing to sell it to anyone.„ he added hastily when she gave him a stern look.

„The captain always knows what she's doing, even if some of you sometimes say otherwise.„ First Mate Tonado gave the bosun a superior look. He was the only officer and pirate in general who sat at her table. He occupied the place that Reh-zar usually occupied, and she missed him very much, especially now, when the treasure she had found, which she had wanted for so long, turned out to not bring the solace she had hoped for.

They were in the mess hall, which had now become the place to celebrate their easy victory. There were treasures on the tables, mainly artifacts previously taken from Horde-Prime, who in turn took them from the civilizations he conquered. Many of them no longer existed, which made them much more valuable than Kaert thought, if only they could prove that they were the last remnants of a people annihilated by a mad tyrant... Yes, they had acquired a great fortune at almost no cost. Almost…

„Captain, don't worry about the girl... She just got lost somewhere along the way, but she'll be found before we know it! „ said Petty Officer Kaert, waving his hand. Tonado looked at him and said with irritation in his voice.

„She's not as stupid and clumsy as you all want her to be! It was thanks to her that we managed to rob it all. If she hadn't scouted, we would all have wandered around this city until we ran into that admiral's soldiers, or worse yet, that monster that attacked in the dark. We should all drink to her health now, right after we drink to the Captain's health.” He banged his four fists on the table. Skittermander liked and understood their navigator. They were both seen as weaker than others. It was enough for Tonado to draw his sabers to silence all the taunts, for a girl with a body destroyed by the toxic environment of Jadehell it was much more difficult. They were both absolutely loyal to their Captain, and not only because there was nothing waiting for them outside the pirate ship, no dreams… Nothing at all.

“Actually, we could have bumped into them because you had another task.” Kaert said and laughed. The Skittermander growled and started to get up from the table, but she signaled him to stay where he was and spoke to the boatswain in a warning tone.

“Be careful what you say and to whom... And as for Tirin, she is not a stupid girl who would drink in a tavern and let someone escape through the toilet!” she recalled a certain failure involving Verthani traveling on Bina's ship.

Keart scratched his head, clearly embarrassed

„I'm sorry, Captain, but when I have a drink, I start talking whatever comes to my mind. And I had something to drink, because we did great... You know, Captain? If I can be honest, we should stay here permanently. We are the only real pirates here. Aside from that Lord Admiral and those Prime heirs, I think we're the only ones with a decent warship here, and once your guy gets here with his new ship, everyone's going to be a force to be reckoned with. I'm thinking that we could come to an agreement with the Lord Admiral and ask him for a letter of marque or something like that... After all, she's a galactic bigwig, not the queen of some provincial planet... Please forgive me, Captain!” he bowed to her apologetically when he realized what stupidity she had said.

„You're right, Boatswain, when you drink, you talk terrible nonsense, so I'll forgive you for what you just said, and as for your proposal, it's worth considering.” she said completely honestly, and Boatswain, satisfied with her answer, returned to the partying. What he said was an interesting idea, because cooperation with someone like Antares made sense. Although he was human, his daughter was a mixed breed, and from what she heard, he treated his subordinates equally, regardless of their species. While there were sinister rumors about him, there were all kinds of dark stories told about her, although she had to admit that many of them were true. Maybe if they joined forces, they would succeed... What was she thinking? She didn't come here to build an empire, but... To reclaim her inheritance... Only it was Etheria... A planet ruled by her daughter... Her daughter was alive... For so many years she was sure that her daughter was dead... And she robbed her... At her own wedding...

„Captain.” asked Tonado in Skittermander version of conspiratorial tone, the kind that would attract the attention of everyone around them if they weren't drunk. :I'm not questioning your decisions, nothing like that, the Captain knows very well that I would gladly give my life for you, one word would be enough...„ he was saying with absolute sincerity, but she interrupted him.

„I love you, Tonado, and I don't doubt your loyalty, but please, get to the point.” she smiled, because no one else had cheered her up so much , except maybe Tirin. Skittermander took a deep breath and said aloud what she had just been wondering .

„Why won't Mrs. Captain meet her daughter? I'm talking about the family and things like that, I know that sometimes things are different in the family, but from what I've noticed, it seems to me that she's a good girl and she certainly didn't have a hand in what happened to you. Maybe it would be worth... I don't know, talk to her or something...„ Skittermander looked down in shame. She wiped her face with her hand and smiled sadly.

„It's not that simple... I admit that ever since I found this sword, I started wondering... Why am I hiding from her... This weapon... it was supposed to bring me answers to all my questions... It was supposed to fix everything, but when I look at it, I only see a few pieces of metal, completely useless. If only someone would take him away from my eyes, I wouldn't be able to think about anything else, as if someone had forced these thoughts into my head... „ and she fell silent , because she suddenly had an epiphany.

“He's a fucking blood-sucking bastard!” she screamed, and all her crew members present in the mess hall looked at her. However, before she could fully formulate this thought, Gozamund, who was not playing with the others, entered the mess and said.

„There's a problem, Captain... Someone sent an announcement and you have to come with me.” said the gloomy Nuar , and she nodded and followed him…

He looked at his sword, smiling to himself, only when no one was looking, of course. So actually, not very often, but he was still so happy... He was a hero, a real hero! He defeated a terrible monster and saved Scorpia . The former Force Captain was nice to him and he liked her, as did everyone else. When he used this

sword, he became brave, strong, powerful... He just felt invincible, it was so wonderful! He, Kyle, the biggest lame duck of the Horde and then the People's Rebellion, could finally become useful, help others... So what if no one knew the truth? He didn't want to be a hero for fame... He wanted to help others, that was all that mattered to him... One day, he will tell all about it to his friends and loved ones... For example, on his deathbed... And then he will die immediately, so as not to see the disappointment in Rogelio's eyes and Lonnie's furious outburst... Maybe his girlfriend won't have time to kill him...

„Hey Blonde Boy, sorry to bother you while you're playing with your sword, there's an issue.„ he heard Eti's voice from the side and he jumped with fear... As Kyle, he wasn't even half as brave as when he was the Other. Eti wasn't half as scary as Catra, though he didn't want to tell her that, but she found him in a moment looking at his sword... That probably sounded weirder than it should have. He sheathed the blade and smiled insincerely.

„Oh, Eti, it's good to see you... and Rosie is here.” he looked at the nice deaf girl who scared him much more than Catra's Sister. “I see that you also brought a prisoner.” he looked at the girl wearing strange overalls. She had disturbing almost monochromatic eyes and half-translucent hair. She seemed nice, but she was probably hiding some secret that would make her scary.

This is Tirin, and she would like to ask you about the Captain Wingy, you know, she used to be your queen or something... „ Eti explained in that dull voice. Tirin nodded and seemed to even smile, although he couldn't see her mouth because she was wearing an oxygen mask and when she spoke, her voice didn't come out of her mouth.

„Captain Moonshadow always claimed to be from here, but she didn't know she was... well, a queen... She always acted like she was just like us... like prisoners, that is, not like me...”

He was aware that Queen Angela was alive, Shadow Weaver had told Lonnie about it, and she had repeated it to the rest, though he didn't care much... To them, the Queen of Etheria had always been a distant and unimportant figure that they knew almost nothing about. They got to know her daughter Glimmer much better, who had faced them many times... However, one thing interested him in the words of the girl in the strange suit.

„What did you mean, not like you?" he asked curiously. Tirin looked down and said as if she was embarrassed.

„I am Azlanti, a pure-blooded one, a citizen of an empire that proclaims the supremacy of the human race..."

„The Azlanti are terrible, they enslave members of other species. Mixed relationships in their empire are prohibited under penalty of death, and hybrids are killed on the spot. We fought them on the way here." Rosie added and glanced at Eti when she mentioned the ban on mixed relationships and the killing of Hybrids. A shiver ran through him. Would anyone want to kill him and Rogelio just because they're together? This is a monstrosity worthy of Horde Prime ... He looked at the girl with fear, and she lowered her eyes, very sad.

„My people have committed many evil deeds that you here on Etheria don't even immagine... she said and wiped her eyes with a handkerchief, which she put in the compartment of her suit." Excuse me, do you have a toxic waste container around here somewhere? Because these are my tears...

He felt sorry for her. He himself served in the Etherian Horde, which may not have been as terrible as the Galactic Horde, but had also done a lot of evil. They were victims, but also perpetrators, although Lonnie seemed to forget that sometimes. He didn't know who the Azlanti were, but they certainly weren't born evil and could become good if they wanted to, at least sometimes they needed a little help. It was the same with them, with Catra, and even Hordak ... He walked up to Azlanti and hugged her, although he wasn't sure if it was pleasant for

someone wearing such an outfit. Tirin smiled again, this time it felt like a much warmer smile, and she returned the hug. But then a voice came from the intercom.

„Rosie, Eti, can you bring Tirin to the bridge because we will be talking to Moonshadow and it would be good for us to show that we didn't eat her or that.” the voice seemed to belong to that strange and terrible creature living in the tank inside the ship. He was afraid of him too, so he obeyed without a murmur and followed the others.

“So I stormed into the Power Plant and started yelling that they had to surrender on behalf of the Lord Admiral, and if they didn't want to do it, they would have to deal with him and Grand Marshal Catra. Strangely enough, they were much more scared by our Eti's sister than Antares, cursed by devils and demon , although maybe that shouldn't surprise me. Even without the authority of power, Eti can scare those who don't know her.” She was telling to Wrongdak, Ireanis and the even stranger girl with purple hair that she seemed to have control over. Her name was Entrapta, and she was apparently a princess, as was Huntara, a term used extremely broadly here.

„Catra used to often resort to threats and intimidation as a method of exercising power, but she has changed a lot and hardly uses them anymore.” the technician said, constantly writing something down on her Datapad.

„It's very interesting.” she said, remembering Igzar, the uncle of both girls, were such behaviors hereditary? – Anyway, I had to tie a rag around my face because I didn't have a half-mask on hand, but I'm great at parodying Ka, too good, because then I start acting like a bigger freak even than her, and believe me, it's quite a feat. They got so terrorized that they followed all my commands as if someone was aiming at them... Although that's basically what I did, so maybe I shouldn't be surprised. Anyway, we are all safe and happy now.” she finished her story and looked at

everyone, expecting delighted glances, because this time she was very proud of herself. She received them from all but one

„Shadow Weaver may be safe, because she's probably out of danger, but she's definitely not happy.” Entrapta explained and started looking around the bridge. Well, maybe that wasn't the best of her anecdotes, she'll tell it better next time, when she'll think it over. Despite everything, she was happy. Her kids were by her side, and most importantly, safe and sound, at least for now, and the dark bitch was trapped. Even Dilayla and the others were safe, Huntara informed her about it. Yes, the future seemed uncertain, but there was no point in worrying in advance.

Of course, a lot has changed in her absence. First of all, her wards joined the People's Rebellion. It was apparently the idea of Shadow Weaver, who wanted to hide from the Lord Admiral in a fortress hidden in the mountains, although her children eagerly approved of this idea, but this should not be surprising, Itel has always been a rebel, always attracted to various anti-system individuals and soldiers, and Comrade General Lonnie was both. She reluctantly had to admit that the idea was theoretically good, because under the circumstances the most important thing was to find protection from the Lord Admiral, but they didn't have to get so involved in this idiotic conflict. She wasn't sure if Shadow Weaver had encouraged them to do this, to get revenge on her former friends, she would have to ask Rosie and Eti about it, both girls were even too honest.

Rosie and Eti. In fact, she knew from the very beginning that they were attracted to each other, so when she found out that they were a couple, she happily applauded them. The former intern fit Eti and had a soothing effect on her, soothing her aggressive instincts. And the cat-like girl protected the white-haired girl from the mean world, although she was not sure how much the deaf girl needed anyone's protection. Alatar briefly told her about what happened between Rosie and Itel. Rosie admitted that Lady Cala's expedition was linked to the Lord Admiral from the very beginning, and then the Elf attacked her with a moonblade, although she suspected that the main reason was jealousy of the

shooter. She had no grudge against the former intern, who knew absolutely nothing about Antares' true nature or his very close ties to Eti... She could have been much more furious with Dilayla , but from what she understood from Huntara's message, Lady Cala rewarded her for her silence with an attempt. murders. She wasn't sure of the connection between the beautiful Aristocrat and the Lord Admiral, and from the behavior of the cursed sorceress she could conclude that they probably didn't work for Antares . Well, she probably should have trusted Eti's nose very literally from the very beginning. As for Rosie and Itel's conflict, it ended when the former intern started throwing tanks and then almost killed Elf, but Eti stopped her. Anyway, things were good between them now, the girls apologized and reconciled... At least in theory, because Itel tried to kill the Lord Admiral on her own, which ended very badly...

It all started when itel decided to break into Brightmoon Castle because she didn't believe that others weren't as crazy as her and would dismantle weapons of mass destruction. It was hard to believe, but this whole crazy thing wasn't Shadow Weaver's idea. In the end, the break-in ended with Eti's imprisonment, which might not have been so bad because he would have met his sister under controlled conditions, but then Antares showed up and everything changed. Now they were embroiled in a conflict that could destroy them all.

And you are responsible for it. She looked at the two girls entering the bridge and told Wrongdak and Ireanis to leave them . Lonnie and Itel, both of them had gotten them into this mess that she would have to get them out of somehow, or rather they would all have to get themselves out of... Comrade General was limping, and she was leaning on the cane they had lent her. Apparently she had a close encounter with someone armed with a storm hammer, and was saved by Wrongdak... He really was a nice and helpful guy. Lonnie looked like someone her age, and was chronologically older than her, but after exchanging a few words with her, she realized that she was actually a kid who didn't have the opportunity to fully grow up because she was raised in the barracks. She only knew one thing and didn't understand the real

world, so she decided to escape from it into the one she knew and understood. The problem was that once you challenged the world, there was no way back. Itel was more seriously injured, although from what she heard, if it weren't for Entrapta, her fucked up sister would have blown her head off. However, it was Itel that she was more furious with. Lonnie had every right to not know who she was messing with, but itel knew the threat very well. She exposed them all to a terrible fate, even though she always claimed that her friends were the most important to them.

"Oh, my two Mean Chaos Queens have arrived" she said, crossing her arms over her chest and smiling sarcastically. Lonnie scowled at her and said, trying to sound tough.

„I am a Comrade General of the People's Rebellion, not a queen… „ she had no intention of letting her finish.

„One does not exclude the other, and besides, on my ship, you are to address me as Captain." she said, still smiling. Someone had to bring this girl down to earth before she hurt herself or someone else with her arrogance.

„You have no right to admonish me! Who are you...„ Lonnie started, turning red with anger, but she interrupted her again so that the girl wouldn't take the initiative.

„I told you, I am the captain of this ship and on board my word is law. Even your Shadow Weaver understood that, although from what I heard she was a mean and sadistic bitch. You can play this People's Rebellion, please, but don't involve me or my kids in it." she approached Lonnie, who was much more massively built, but she still seemed to be in control of the situation. Lonnie didn't understand that a true Leader is determined by how others perceive him. There was no real force needed, just projection. Antares, Shadow Weaver and probably even Adora understood this, although the last one did it subconsciously, of course she did not know this girl well enough to be able to express her opinion.

„I'm not messing around, and if your crew decides to leave us, they'll be considered deserters!” drawled Comrade General, but she just shook her head and replied with undisguised contempt.

„So what about this? Don't think you can scare me. I knew Igzar and he was terrible. When he was in a good and happy mood, he was like your Catra in her worst moments. And yes, I'll tell you again, you're playing rebellion. Nobody on this planet cares about you. Some people may support some of your demands, maybe they would even be ready to shout for you, but they will not be ready to die for you... or kill. You may think you have allies, but believe me, to all of them you are just a tool with which to fight proxy wars. People like you are always just tools. Maybe if you were as cunning as Igzar or Antares you could use this to your advantage, but you're not. Even Itel didn't join you because she cares about your vendetta with Eti’s sister, but because she needed you to fight the Lord Admiral, as evidenced by the fact that she attacked him with her blade when she had the chance. opportunity.”

Lonnie looked at Itel, who looked down. She approached the green-haired Elf and, looking her straight in the eyes, said in a much gentler, even sad voice.

„I'm disappointed in you, Itel, I'm very disappointed. It's not about breaking into the castle, as idiotic as that was. Or even the fact that you attacked Rosie with a blade because you were jealous of Eti. But because of your sheer child like thoughtlessness, you put a lot of people at risk of death. How many people died because of you...”

„Three.” Eti's voice rang out from behind her. She turned and looked at the cat girl with everyone else. She came with Rosie and Tirin, and also that blond man who still had that sword on his belt, even though he looked like he could hurt himself with it. “There will now be eleven in total.” The cat girl continued.

What are you talking about?“ When she saw Itel lower her eyes, she understood what the shooter was referring to.

„Yesterday I killed three people, so I have eleven kills in total, and it's only two thousand two hundred and sixty days old... Quite a feat.” Eti said in a voice that this time contained anger, bitter amusement and sadness, a very toxic mix. “I did it for you, Itel... If you hadn't wanted to kill my father, they would still be alive. I know they weren't good beings, but I'll still have to live with it... thank you, Itel.” she said, not taking her eyes off the Elf.

"I... I'm sorry..." she said, tears streaming down her face.

„You're welcome. „ said the cat girl and laughed such a painful, joyless laugh that Bina had difficulty refraining from hugging her, because Eti hated it. But to her surprise, when Rosie wrapped her in a tight hug right after, Eti relaxed and rested her head on her girlfriend's shoulder. There was silence because no one knew what to say to this confession. Lonnie broke the silence.

„I took the lives of three people... At least, because I fired from the tank several times and I'm not sure of the results. The first was a rebel women from Thymor, it was during our first Action. That was when Adora first came against us. She attacked me unnecessarily because we were already retreating. I guess she felt a surge of bravado because of what She-Ra and the others did... She had a knife in her hand, I don't know what she wanted to do, but she was threatened me and wouldn't drop the weapon, so I hit her and took her prisoner. It was only during transport that I realized that she was dead.” Lonnie's voice changed during this story. She was no longer the great leader of the People's Rebellion, all her stubbornness and anger were gone. At this point, she was just a kid again who was forced to do bad things.

„It was accident the first time I took a life... „ Itel said. „ It was during the Swarm invasion, before I got to the refugee camp... I fell asleep on the boat and when I woke up, a woman approached her... She wanted to get into my boat, but I got scared and stabbed her with a knife... „ she spoke in a quiet voice, devoid of her frequent anger.

„I only killed once.” Kyle said without looking anyone in the eye. “It was when we occupied one of the towns... There was this old man there. He was furious because someone had ruined his garden... He picked on me, started shouting at me and pushing me... Finally, he pushed me hard and then I shocked him... Instinctively, I didn't want to do anything to him, but his heart couldn't stand it. I tried to help him, I even took him to a field hospital... Rogelio helped me, I didn't want to tell you anything, I haven't talked to Rogelio about it since then... With anyone.” the boy didn't cry. His eyes where so empty

„I killed fifty-four people.” Tirin said suddenly. Everyone looked at her in disbelief. „I do not regret it. It was in the Jadehell labor camp . It's... A terrible place. I was the daughter of the camp commandant. After he died, I stayed there... No one paid any attention to me, I was just a pathetic crippled girl whose existence was an insult to all the ideals of the empire. But I kept all the codes and access cards... Captain Moonshadow was planning a mutiny... I decided to help. While there was a fall of Skullrot, an extremely murderous spore, I decided to unseal the soldiers' barracks. It was a very painful death... But they deserved it. They did terrible things to prisoners...„ explained the girl. Her voice was confident… Well, as soon as she found out that Tirin worked for Captain Moonshadow, she was relieved because she liked this girl and could feel sympathy for her, and now she realized that she had to keep an eye on her as well.

„Once, at the very beginning of my work for the Horde, I hacked a network of runestones...„ Entrapta said in a quiet voice, with her back turned to them. No one had paid any attention to her until now. “This led to a cataclysm on a planetary scale. It may not have lasted long, but the damages where... significant.”

Bina looked at the inventor, who was cowering inwardly as if overwhelmed by the responsibility for what she had done. Well, the whole galaxy should be keeping an eye on her….

„I once heard that everyone is guilty, but not everyone got the punishment they deserved... For me, it's just bullshit. I much

prefer the words the priestess of Cayden once told me . She said that it doesn't matter what we did, but how we feel about it. Truth be told, I'm not an authority on morality. So why don't we end this difficult day with a talk with Captain Moonshadow and then get some sleep in Castle Crypto, what do you say?" she asked everyone gathered. As they slowly gave her thoughtful nods one by one, she asked Tirin to make contact with the Captain who had once been queen.

She was glad she didn't drink that day. Generally speaking, she avoided alcohol abuse, and for a pirate, she was practically a teetotaller. Now she needed a clear and sober mind. She had to be absolutely focused on the negotiations. With only Gozamund and Tonado on the communications screen, she decided it would be better if the rest of her crew were unaware of what might be at stake during these conversations. It was a good thing that she was completely sober, because when she saw what she saw on the screen, she would seriously wonder if she was drunk. She saw Bina, along with her two wards, Itel and Eti, and this deaf girl named Rosie, who had apparently also become a member of their ship's crew. Apart from them, there was a dark"skinned woman leaning on a crutch, a blond"haired boy with a strange sword at his belt, and a purple"haired woman whose long ponytails clapped at the sight of her. The most important person was not immediately visible, but despite her frail stature, Tirin made her way to the very front of the crowd gathered in front of the screen. She was relieved to see that she was fine, except for a black eye.

„I'm terribly sorry, Captain, but I was about to run in, but I bumped into Rosie and she hit me, but she's very sorry." she pointed to the deaf girl, who hung her head apologetically. "I'm fine, I'm just a kind of prisoner now , but not entirely..."

„Of course you are our prisoner!" exclaimed the woman leaning on the crutch. "I am Comrade General Lonnie and I demand from you… „ she did not finish because Bina interrupted her.

„Maybe I'll take care of it, honey, because, don't be offended, but I'm better at negotiations and things like that... My father has already taken care of it.” She smiled grimly, and Lonnie looked at her resentfully, but not too much, because then she collapsed onto the crutch, clearly exhausted. “I admit that I was a bit shocked when I found out that you were the queen and everything, but you were probably more shocked... It should surprise me, but it doesn't , which I think shows what a fucked up world we live in. Personally, I would give you Tirin without any conditions, because he's a nice kid, but it so happens that maybe an equally nice kids made a deal with this Lonnie and she wants Adora's sword from you, which you stole from the museum.” when she heard that it was Adora's sword, she almost interrupted Bina , but she caught herself in time. She finally knew the truth, or at least she suspected it. „In my opinion, it's just a worthless piece of iron... To put it simply, so if I were you, I wouldn't hesitate. I'm not someone who has the right to lecture anyone on life choices, but I feel like there are more important things you should be concerned with right now.”

She thought for a few minutes what she should do, and no one on the other side dared to interrupt her, although she could see that the purple-haired woman was just waiting to bombard her with questions, they probably knew each other from their old life, although she couldn't remember her name, she only had the impression that it was connected with some very sad events. Finally she was ready and said.

„My conditions are these. Comrade General will issue me a Letter of Marque and agree to supply my people with supplies, and you will give me a place on your staff. There will be a few more things related to the chain of command, but that's something you should accept." She said in a serious voice. Lonnie, when she heard her terms, immediately nodded, after all, they were more than generous. “There's just one more thing. You will answer my question, Bina, but absolutely honestly. I'm guessing you didn't buy this ship penny by penny. Tell me who your patron is.”

Bina hesitated for a moment, as did Itel, but then Eti spoke.

„Doctor Sidonius, who else could do that?”

„Yes, there are so few people in the galaxy who have ever heard of my home planet... Do you have any way to contact him?” she asked, smiling under her mask.

Dr. Sidonius felt filled with guilty pleasure. He drank real blood while preying on wedding guests. He didn't kill anyone, he wasn't out of practice, even though he hadn't hunted for many years. It was also nice to observe all these people, the queen, the Grand Marshal, the monster from the Dark Between the Stars and others, completely unaware of its existence. He wasn't a voyeur or anything like that, but there was a certain wicked pleasure in looking at others without being seen. Now he wasn't even sure if he would leave this place to join the Archduke, because being so close to the royal court had many advantages.

He suddenly felt that the certain gem he had given to the certain extraordinary group of kids he had sent ahead to help him search this planet, the cure to Captain Blazebringer's terrible ailment, was just as important, if not more important. He had almost forgotten about those kids, only yesterday when he was following Catra witnessed the meeting of both sisters, although from what he managed to determine, it was not their first meeting, which is a pity because he would have liked to see their reaction, especially Catra's. And so, the most interesting thing about the whole event was meeting this strange white-haired girl. She defeated She-Ra, even though she was not in the best mental state, but it was still something amazing. He regretted not sending his daughter with them, because she would have watched the activities of Bina's crew closely. She and Eti liked each other very much. But then she would be within Lady Cali's reach, and he had no intention of putting her through that. After all, his daughter was all that was really important to him. Except for the memories that were taken from him. He smiled darkly to himself and took a small datapad and entered a special encrypted channel. He didn't expect who he would see on the screen at all.

„I am so glad to se you after so many years, Dr. Sidonius.” Captain Moonshadow said. At first he was even happy to see her, this woman was very useful, and an additional spaceship could be very useful in this situation. However, he saw coldness in the eyes visible above the mask.

„ Oh, I'm so pleased. Probably yo, what you recently learned about yourself was extremely surprising to you, but with absolute honesty I must assure you that for me... „ he said as politely as he could, but the captain didn't let him finish.

„Save it to yourself, you fucking leech!” the woman growled at him. “I already know what you did to me…”

„But what did I do to you? If I remember, it was thanks to me that you managed to free yourself from Azlantean captivity... Right?” he said, holding back his anger at being called a leech.

„You didn't do it out of the goodness of your heart... You implanted a lie in my mind... the need to obtain the artifact that you saw in my mind... You could have restored my memories... But instead you distorted them. You only did it because you wanted it„ she showed him the sword broken in half... „You won't get it... I'll give it to someone who will make better use of it.”

Feel his dead heart fill with fury.

„You stupid idiot! You can't understand what's at stake!” he shouted at Moonshadow.

„ In this game, my life is at stake... mine and my daughter's, which you treated as just another resource to be used up in your damned game... Enough of this!” and she hung up. For a moment, the ancient vampire stared ahead, trying to quench the cold undead anger smoldering in his heart. He knew that it was Bina and her children who gave the pirate information about him, but unfortunately he couldn't get back at them in any way, because he would still need their help... But as for the not-so-former queen... she had a few weak points... she herself revealed

them to him... In a sense, he understood her well. After all, for every parent, children are the most important thing.

Chapter End Notes

Did you enjoy this chapter? Did Tirin surprise you with her confession?

Things that we do out of love

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Calamity wasn't frustrated. Not even angry. She also had no desire to grab someone and tear off their limbs one by one. Not any more. Now she was completely calm. She did splatter the walls with her own blood when she tried to break them by banging on them with her fists. The sparkling slut made sure the walls and other defenses could withstand her fury. A hypocrite, she talked so much about how the people of her kingdom valued freedom and justice, and she built a prison using Horde Prime's technology. She used her magic tricks to trap her here. This detention was absolutely against the law and no charges were brought against her. She doubted that the Queen would be allowed to detain civilians like that, without the slightest reason. They should send some guards or a sheriff to get her. She would kill them, of course, after all, they would ask for it when they went against her, but you had to follow certain legal procedures if you called yourself a law-abiding ruler. In fact, she was the only victim here. First, this sneaky mercenary attacked her, she must skin alive those inept cultists she gave her to. And then that damn Hell Knight tried to murder her by stabbing her in the back. She was technically defenseless! Of course, the Lady of the Blades didn't have a chance to take life of being so magnificent as her, but it didn't matter! It was an attempted murder. Any lawyer in a civilized country would defend her, but what could you expect from a country where beasts could hold the highest state offices?

But it wasn't the obvious injustice of being imprisoned here that was the worst. These women ignored her! They rejected her generous offer of help! They believed that, despite all their

immense ignorance, they would be able to cope with what was coming! Those words... They were the worst... How dare she call her that!

„Princess of Nothingness! Let the winged bitch go to hell!” she screamed and, to emphasize her words, she hit the energy shield constituting the door with all her strength. She felt all the bones, from her hand to her forearm, being crushed by the force of the impact. It didn't hurt her, she never felt pain, just a slight discomfort rather warning her not to attract suspicion with her divine gifts. Immediately after, her limbs regenerated, but it didn't change anything, she was still trapped, and had to wait for someone from outside to help her. Shadow Weaver was imprisoned, either due to her own stupidity or soft heart. Why didn't she come to this woman when she was at her peak, but now, when she was a shuddering wreck? She wasn't sure that cursed sorceress would want to help her. After all, the relationship between them had always been strained, through no fault of hers of course, and now the dark sorceress had an excuse to abandon her here, because she still had a mission to complete and such nonsense. Although since she was imprisoned it didn't matter anyway, she only wished that the locals were like the Azlanti and would do to her mentor something similar to what happened to the queen's mother... Fortunately, she also had other allies, much more loyal and giving her due respect, although unfortunately their competences left much to be desired, the best proof of which was the fact that they allowed that damn mercenary to escape. Could she count on them not to let her down this time? Unfortunately, she had already gotten used to the fact that life was not fair for her and that she could only count on herself... That's why she started implementing a plan... Sadly, it required time, but fortunately, she had enough of it. She smiled to herself as she used a long claw to cut into her skin and began to draw a secret circle with her own blood. "Oh Blackwind, I missed you," she thought nostalgically.

Since Catra, Glimmer, and Adora's visit, she had been kneeling on the floor, staring at the wall. She failed. She let down Nyarlathotep, Catra, Glimmer, Lonnie, Mikah ... She let everyone down, but honestly, she should be used to it by now. Throughout her life, she let down those who counted on her. Yes, she was the great disappointment... She always looked for blame in others, others were responsible for her mistakes and failures... And in fact, her whole life was a failure.... She always had big plans, big ambitions, but in fact, they were all lies. The delusions of a bitter mind intoxicated with power and alcohol. She saw herself as a great heroine, a savior who would finally bring new order to Etheria. Whom everyone will admire for her merits and tremble before her wrath... She was no better in her pride and self-righteousness than Calamity. Even now she imagined that she would save everyone and be the savior of all Etheria. That all you have to do is just say sorry and everything will be forgiven, and the daughters to whom she was never a mother will throw themselves into her arms and be a happy family. She hasn't changed at all since she believed she could be forgiven after all she had done... There is no respite for the wicked.

But she had to escape from here somehow, because she knew that Etheria was in so many dangers... Except she wasn't sure how to do it. The circle that surrounded her was created by Glimmer, and she was a powerful Sorceress, even she herself become more powerful once her ritual was improved. She saw that the Queen made a few mistakes while casting it, she was really exhausted, and she herself had learned a lot during her stay on Carurystal. Perhaps she could break it, but not without alerting the guards, and then she would have to fight. First with Brightmoon's guard , and then with Glimmer and the rest... It would be pointless... Even if she had enough power to win this fight, but that wasn't the only point. She didn't want to leave a trail of dead bodies behind her, to become a symbol of betrayal and destruction again... She had to get out of here in another, more subtle way... She was, after all, a master of shadow magic, a mistress of deceit and trickery. She could sneak and hide in the dark. She knew something about illusion magic. She was unable

to teleport from here, because while freeing Eti, she discovered that the castle was secured against teleportation attempts by unauthorized persons, both those wanting to get in and out. Lessons were probably learned from her intrusion into the palace during the war. However, it was a problem she was able to deal with. All she had to do was get outside the castle walls... Only... Still the biggest problem was breaking the circle in such a way that no one, especially Glimmer, would realize that she had gotten out... She knew several ways. She had known how to move to the shadow dimension for a long time. although in the old days she rarely used it because it drained her power too quickly... Now she had a chance... She could also move to one of the more distant planes, the existence of which she learned about only after she left Etheria. She could also summon one of the creatures from both the lower planes or the Darkness Between The Stars. Maybe for example Byakhe, which would make it easier for her to get out of here... She just knew it would take time, and according to Catra, she might not have much of it. Halo, one of Star's sisters... She only met her once, during that Battle, when the fate of the First Rebellion was sealed... She and her sister Pulsar tried to prevent her from performing that ritual, with Mikah helping them. They had a chance to win then, they would have succeeded if Neutriono had joined the fight, but the third of the Star Sisters had remained on the Isles... She was prepared for someone to try to interrupt her. She ordered additional soldiers to hide , and also used a few tricks... She struck Halo with dark magic, the woman deserved respect for surviving her attack, and she tested a certain nanite plague on Pulsar, which she brought back from that one and only trip to Beast Island, from which she and Hordak barely escaped. Then she heard that Halo had managed to escape with her sister's body. After that, she was no longer interested in her fate. The islands withdrew from the war and never supported the Rebellion again. They are no longer relevant. Now, however, she would have to answer for what she had done to them, another sin she would have to face... She wasn't sure what Halo had planned for her, but in the old days she had heard many dark rumors about the secrets hidden by the inhabitants of the islands. Back then, she took them for gossip and fairy tales, but life taught her

that there was much more than a grain of truth hidden in dark tales. There was one more thing... The plague that Pulsar had infected didn't kill her... She tested it on several insects and learned how it worked... Pulsar wasn't dead, as most of the planet's inhabitants thought... No... She condemned her to a fate worse than death. Will the other sisters want to repay her in the same way?

She knew that staring blankly ahead would do nothing to help her plan her escape, but she didn't have the strength to focus on that. Catra told her the truth, she almost destroyed her life for no reason, just because she was full of malicious rage... There is no redemption for her. But she wasn't looking for it, at least not at first... Asindesa was right. She was playing with their love, and yet she had to be aware that she would bring danger to her beloved... She knew that who she was and who she served would make her choose between her order and the woman she loved. She should have told her everything before she stole her heart... No... She should never have approached her. This was the only way she could save her... Save them both... But she chose differently... she thought that somehow everything would work out. Was she under the illusion that the Lady of the Blades wouldn't guess anything? She abandoned her alone in the midst of this terrible truth, leaving her to the mercy of creatures like Lady Cala and the Lord Admiral. She had to struggle alone with her shame ... and if anyone in the order found out the truth... Devils and demons, she sentenced her to death... This sudden revelation made her heart freeze for a moment, struck with fear. She did it again. First, she sent Mikah to Beast Island, and then she used Catra, to escape from prison knowing what punishment awaited her from Hordak. Now, she did it third time. She thought she had become at least a little better, but in fact there was as much evil in her heart as before... She lived only to hurt her loved ones. When she realized this, she hid her face in her hands, realizing that there was no forgiveness for her. Tears streamed down her face, but as her mother used to say, tears are worth as much as raindrops...

Nightgale felt almost no fear. Almost... But she was determined and sure of what she was going to do. She felt like nothing could stop her... Not even She-Ra and the princesses... She couldn't fail, she just couldn't! She knew what she was about to do was unimaginable, terrifying, and maybe just plain stupid, but she had to do it… She had to save her mother…

„Mortals can do incredible things in the name of love.” said Aravos, floating next to her. Star Saihe smiled slightly thoughtfully.

„Apparently you've never loved anyone... Has anyone ever loved you?„ she asked quietly, hoping that no one would be interested in the fact that she was talking to herself.

„Well, I once had a sister... She loved me... „ Aaravos said , smiling much happier than before. Touched by sudden anxiety, she asked.

„And what happened to her?”

The strange, horned wizard sighed dramatically before speaking.

„She died, it's a very sad story.” he made a sad face, but there was no sadness in his unnatural, sparkling eyes … she shuddered. *What kind of people do I work with*? she thought, but immediately answered herself. *With those that are, they will help me save those I love*. She loved her mother, she was sure of that as much as anything in the world. Even though she had known her for a dozen or so days, she loved her, she didn't expect it. She had long known that Shadow Weaver was alive and would return. Back then she thought of her with bitter fatalism, expecting him to reject her, just like her father had done... That's why she loved her... because she accepted her for who she was, or rather what she was... Only Scarlet and Frosta knew the truth about her. But the former was dead, and Frosta… Her mother wasn't aiming at the Ice Princess, she was sure of that. Her target was Lady Ka. This didn't surprise her , deep down she felt that there was something wrong with this woman. Lady Cala... She was an alien being, beyond the realm of mortal morality... But Lady Ka... Her

evil and villainy was more down to earth, but that made it much more repulsive. She had no idea what had happened between Lady Ka and Shadow Weaver, but her mother must have had a good reason to do it... As for Frosta ... The girl survived, but remained in a coma. She wasn't sure how she could be helped, she wasn't a healer, though she doubted healing magic could do the trick. She was quite knowledgeable in the Dark Arts, and she had an extraordinary new teacher who had knowledge beyond the reach of anyone on Etheria . Perhaps with Aaravos' help she could do something for her, but unfortunately she had to choose. However, if she succeeds in what she set out to do... She will have enough power to save everyone.

Taking Nightgale's identity wasn't difficult. She didn't use much Magic on this mission, and just in case, she took with her everything needed to assume the identity of Castaspelia's assistant . No one stopped her, in fact some were glad that another sorceress was present in the castle, especially since the Head Sorceress and Mikah left the castle without telling anyone what they were going to do, although many assumed that the queen had sent them to investigate the Night Attack... She didn't witness the monster's arrival, but she deduced what it was from the description. No one was sure who defeated this creature. Some believed that Glimmer did it with the help of some strange old woman, others said that it was a terrible dragon serving the Lord Admiral who devoured the monster. She was most interested in the version that the monster was defeated by a tall guy very similar to She-Ra... She guessed who it was. She should take a closer look at Kyle, especially his sword... Before, she couldn't find time for him because so much had happened in her life, but now she would have to take an interest in him. The boy could be extremely useful not only to the Rebellion, but especially to the Creeping Chaos. He could also be a huge threat and she might have to kill him in the future... To her surprise, she found that this thought made her sad. She joined the People's Rebellion with the intention of abandoning it as soon as it was no longer useful. She expected that with one word from her Master, she would have to stab them in the back. However, during this time she managed to

like them. She did not share the ideals of the Rebellion, and she never cared about great matters. Even the Creeping Chaos she served only because of the promise made to her... She didn't know how they would react to her true form. Lonnie would definitely be furious since even Kyle drew his sword at the sight of her, although she wasn't surprised at him. After all, the mere sight of Shadow Weaver supposedly made him faint, and she looked a lot like her mother...

Even though everyone in the castle was scared, no one stopped her as she made her way through the halls of Brightmoon. Even though she stood out even in this form, everyone recognized her as Castaspeli's Assistant . During the wedding preparations, she often ran around the castle to do things for the absent”minded sorceress, so everyone got used to seeing her and no one thought anything of it... Perhaps if she stayed here for a few days, she would start to seem suspicious , but when she frees her mother, she will she was going to leave Brighfmoon for good... Well, she would have to come up with a new cover in the future... Or maybe not... No one knew how long she would work for Lonnie, maybe she would leave Etheria soon... although she had no idea where she could go, after all, the Galaxy was so unimaginably huge … Well, she will do as Nyarlthotep's will dictates , it is always better to agree with her, unless one has the courage to face the consequences of defying the Great Outer God … She wasn't going to do that, after all, she was but a speck in the wind compared to his immeasurable power. But now was not the time to think about such matters. The task before her was difficult enough.

She stood in front of the door to her mother's cell. Now she had to convince the guards to let her in.

„Who are you and what are you looking for here?” said a stocky woman with a visible beer belly, which was not completely covered by the guard's armor. She bowed politely, but not humbly, and said.

"I am Nightgale , assistant to Head Sorceress Castaspelia, and I have come here by order of Queen Glimmer, who has determined

that certain spells securing the prisoner's cell must be improved or there is a risk that Hordak's former right-hand man will escape, and we cannot afford that." she said in the most confident and authoritative tone she could muster. Fortunately, her father also put some valuable things in her head... After all, he wanted her to be his right hand, she had to be able to lead people, wasn't it? The two guards thought for a moment, slowly growing paler and paler, most likely imagining various terrifying visions of Shadow Weaver escaping from prison, until they finally looked at each other and nodded.

„Yes, this person cannot be allowed to escape from prison. My husband and children are waiting for me at home... „ said the stocky woman, and together with the second guard they stepped away from the door... She smiled and as soon as she crossed the threshold, she added.

„Don't disturb me, no matter what you hear. Shadow Weaver will resist and if I lose concentration, the consequences will be dire.” there was a theatrical pathos in her voice, a trait she inherited from her mother… In a sense…

As soon as she entered the bedroom converted into a cell, she saw her mother kneeling and hiding her face in her hands. She knew that Catra had visited her earlier, as well as the Lady of the Blades and the Lord Admiral. She guessed that the encounter with her adoptive daughter had driven the Dark Sorcerer to such a state. For a moment she felt a burning hatred for the cat girl, but then she dimmed it. She understood that the feline woman had reasons to hate Shadow Weaver, but now was not the time to judge who had better reasons to hate who.

„Hello mother, I have come to free you...„ she said to the most hated woman on the entire planet.

The voice broke her from her despairing stupor. She turned around and saw a woman she didn't immediately recognize. After

a while she remembered seeing her in Mystacor when she visited Castaspella , but then the words she had spoken reached her hopeless mind and she felt her heart fill with an unusual mixture of joy and anxiety.

„Nightgale? Have you come back for me? But how… Why!”

Nightgale smiled slyly.

„Nobody knows who I really am. I told you that this figure was Castaspeli's assistant ... No one in the entire castle was surprised by her presence, and I managed to get here without much difficulty!” There was so much pride in her daughter's voice that she smiled, but then the girl became serious and said.

„We don't have much time, I suspect someone will be here in an hour or two, although I heard that Catra is going to give you to Halo... Anyway, I don't know if she'll want to visit you... „ said Nightgale and started to lay out some magic equipment. . She felt a twinge of anxiety…

„What are you going to do?” she asked, looking at the girl focused on her activity.

„I need to deactivate the circle that's keeping you here. But it would be very difficult to do it without anyone sensing that it was being tampered with. Unfortunately, I have neither the power nor the skill to manipulate the structure of spells. But there is a way... Even if it fails, you will be free... Use it... „ She felt uncertainty in her voice. After a moment, however, the young woman shook her head and added. “But it should work now... This time it will be different. It must be... „ now the younger sorceress's voice was so confident, as if she wanted to convince herself of her own words. She looked again at the items her Daughter had brought her, and then she began to understand what she intended to do.

„NO! Do not do this!” she shouted to Nightgale, but she did not stop preparing for the ritual.”

„I'm sorry, Mother, but I have no choice... This is the best way to save you... „ Nightgale began to draw a circle on the floor...

„This can't work... You can't do it without another person... who you'll have to sacrifice... That's how it was designed... I wanted to do it differently, but it didn't work... Mikah helped me, and he was always more powerful than me... And I had decades of experience and you...„ she tried to reason with her daughter, but she smiled darkly.

„My father put into my head some of what you could...I also had good teachers... Excellent ones indeed... „ said Nightgale .

„You don't have enough power anyway.” there was a plea in her voice.

„After the destruction of Heart, Etheria is filled with magic... I can also use all the spells that were cast here by the queen...„ Nightgale was just finishing preparing to perform the ritual...

„It doesn't work like that... It was never possible... Please stop doing it... I... I have accepted my fate... I lost everything... Absolutely everything... Don't ruin your life like I ruined mine.” she knelt before the magic shield. But Nightgale didn't respond, so she looked at the door and started screaming. – Guard Stop her! This woman wants to set me free! She... She's going to summon something terrible... A monster as terrible as Horde Prime! If you stop her, you will become heroes... Like Adora... Like She-Ra... Please... „ she screamed and begged, but no one heard her... She looked around and saw the sound-dampening device that the Lord Admiral had brought... After what happened, Lady Ka forgot to take them... Enraging Antares, she caused the death of her daughter... And then the entire room was enveloped in red light...

Calamity raised an eyebrow when she heard that outside the corridor where her cell was. The two guards were talking to someone, for a moment she wasn't sure who it was, but then she

recognized the voice and smiled to herself. This is true loyalty! Have Horde Prime or Shadow Weaver ever experienced anything like this? Unlimited devotion even in times of defeat? No, such a thing could be obtained through true faith ignited by an experience of divinity... It is said that the mistress of a feline creature once invaded the Horde Prime's flagship , but this was dictated by lust, not higher values. The guards left the corridor, and Klementine stood in front of the Energy barrier . As soon as the girl saw her, she smiled brightly at her. She didn't really like that smile, it definitely lacked reverence and respect, but it was satisfying nonetheless.

„I told them that the queen sent me here to get a confession from you, but I need to have a moment of privacy with you... But I guess they interpreted it differently, because first one whispered something in the other's ear, and then they looked at me sadly and compassion. „ Klementine blushed, She felt a surge of intense anger, because the locals would probably consider the absurd idea of her pleading guilty, despite her innocence obvious to anyone with even an ounce of common sense. “But we have to hurry, because they didn't give us much time... I stole my mother's access cards, they didn't deactivate them because of the respect they had for her.” the girl grimaced and only then remembered the reason why she came here. She smiled at the girl as kindly as she could and said.

„Thank you, Klementine . Your loyalty and dedication will be rewarded.” she said, although personally she considered thanking her for fulfilling her duties as an insult to her dignity, and then, seeing in the girl's eyes that she wanted something more, she approached her, embraced her and kissed her. It was really very nice! She would have to do this more often, with women and men, this and much more.

„But now we really have to go.” Klementine looked at her with the same strange eyes that Catra and Adora looked at each other. She almost grimaced because she really didn't like this association, and then she said to call the girl to order.

„How are you going to deal with the guards?”

The girl was confused when she heard this question.

„I have a gun loaded with tranquilizer darts and a grenade with stun gas... and two gas masks... „ she explained and lowered her head. She suppressed a resigned sigh and said.

I don't need a mask... But you better leave the fighting to me. „ they said, smiling warmly at the girl... And then the guards' patience ran out and they entered. Seeing that the prisoner was outside the cell, they stopped dead in their tracks and this was their biggest and last mistake in their lives. With her superhuman speed, she leapt towards them, and a bone blade emerged from her forearm. She stuck it in the chest of one of the guards, killing him instantly. His brother-in-arms grabbed his energy Halberd. He was going to use it to shock the fugitive, but she grabbed it by the steel shaft and pulled it towards her, tearing it out of his hands. He reached for the gun at his waist, but she tripped him with a kick and then crushed his hand by stomping on it with her foot. The soldier let out a strangled scream, but he didn't have time to alert anyone because she grabbed him by the neck, crushed his throat, and then dragged him effortlessly to her cell. There, she lifted him above the summoning circle she had drawn with her own blood and slit his throat, sprinkling the floor with his ichor, causing the lines she had drawn to glow with purple light. She then turned to Clementine, who was looking at the pair of corpses, pale and in obvious shock. She walked up to her and gently caressed her cheek and said in a gentle voice and in a tender, sweet tone.

„It may all have looked terrible, but remember that it wouldn't have happened without your help. We did it together and this act sealed our love, because it was all done out of love .” and she kissed Klementine, and the circle burned with black fire, announcing the arrival of Black Wind ... Her beloved steed.

Nightgale knew that performing the Ritual of Obtainment would not be easy... But the opportunity that lay before her... Perhaps there were better circumstances to perform it... But she was afraid that she would hesitate, chicken out, and decide to look for another way to gain power. She needed it... To free her mother... To bring Scarlet back to life... To prove to the world that she was not a failure... Yes, she had to succeed, otherwise... She couldn't accept any other possibility...

After a while, she felt the barriers between worlds crumble... Probably all the sorcerers within a radius of many kilometers felt it as well. It was an unpleasant, even painful sensation, but compared to what was to come, it was nothing. For now the Devourer of Light, avatar of the Great Outer God, began to break through the gap in reality. She sensed his unimaginable power. She saw red eyes, crossed out by triple axes. There was no hunger, rage or hatred in them. There lurked within them absolutely alien, impossible for mortals to process, they couldn't even describe them in words. But the foreignness of the mind behind them didn't make him any less dangerous… Now her most difficult task lay before her. She had to control the god, at least until she managed to transform... In right way... She had created barriers to keep him from reaching for her. She created them according to the instructions of Aaravos , who was floating in the air right next to her. His blasé, nonchalant pose disappeared somewhere. He was serious now, even imperious,

„Good, now connect it to the local magic network... Immediately!„ He spoke in a worried voice, as if he did not share his previous confidence. She did as he had shown her back in Castle Crypto, but she expected to have a little more time to practice it. She used enhanced magic detection and saw ribbons of power flowing through Etheria... Several of them reached into the circle that imprisoned her mother... Capturing them was difficult... It took great concentration and great willpower... But she didn't lack it, a lifetime of pain and rejection had made her... that she became strong and tough… She had to be. So she grabbed the ribbons, though it was like catching the wind... But she focused and tightened her mental hands on the ribbon and pulled them

towards the Devourer of Light, who was pressing against the barrier she had created. Even though only a few seconds had passed, the creature had almost shattered it… It had to hurry… So she tugged on the ribbon and dragged it towards the swirling darkness…. And then all the magic in Brightmoon disappeared, just for the blink of an eye... It dissipated all the spells in the area, their power absorbed by the Avatar of Nyarlathotep Both the circle that bound her mother and the barrier that protected her from the Devourer of Light disappeared. Black tendrils of darkness reached out towards her. She tried to move back, but they grabbed her.

“This experiment was as informative as it was unsuccessful…” Aaravo said, his voice full of disappointment as the tentacles dragged her towards one of the countless mouths of the Great Outer God. She screamed

She has experienced a lot of Pain in her life. Punishments ordered by her mother, agony every time the power she stole from the black garnet left her, death in a flash of power. But none of them were as terrible as watching her daughter repeat the same mistake that had made her a slave to the darkness. The ritual initially went well. Nightgale managed to stop the Entity, her daughter was truly extremely talented, but even her skills were not enough to accomplish what she planned. For a moment she had the impression that her daughter was talking to someone, so, touched by a premonition, she cast a true seeing spell and then she saw a horned Elf with shiny, sparkling skin... She remembered him... It was this bastard who had convinced her to perform this ritual... Now everything was becoming clear...

And then she felt a strange tug on the magical net and all the spells in the area disappeared, as if the summoned creature had absorbed her. Both the True Sight spell and the circle that had imprisoned her were gone... And the barrier that had protected Nightgale. The Devourer of Light reached out to the young

woman and grabbed her. But now she was free, so she ran towards the monster and screamed.

„Leave her! She doesn't deserve this... Please!” she begged, but the creature simply ignored her... She was just a fly buzzing around the Giant's head... So she started throwing Spells, but they were scattered before they reached their target. She used more and more powerful magic, but what could her secret knowledge and Power do against God?

„Please... Don't do to her what you did to me... Please.” she said, kneeling before the ancient being. However, her pleas and pleas were in vain... After a while, the summoned Avatar of Creeping Chaos gave Nightgale back, but the transformation had already taken place... The girl cowered, and her body was marked, scars appeared in exactly the same places where their shadows had previously been inherited from her mother, as if she was destined to do this deed from the moment of her birth.. In a sense, it was like that... But not because of who she was born, but whose child she was. Anyone who wanted to get close to her was destined to suffer... Nightgale's entire body trembled, torn apart by spasms of indescribable pain... She remembered itso well... She ran to her daughter and wrapped her in the tails of her robe.

„It hurts, it hurts so much. It hurts so much... Mom, help me, make it stop hurting... Please... Make it stop hurting.” the girl pleaded.

„It's okay, darling... I'm with you... I'll help you... „ she said, although she knew well that there was nothing she could do... She could only end her daughter's suffering... For a moment she seriously considered this possibility, but she couldn't give up like that... There had to be way to help the girl.

Focus, don't let yourself get distracted. You have always prided yourself on your knowledge and wisdom... For once, put it to good use... She thought and decided to combine the skills she had developed during her service to the Horde with the knowledge she had acquired during her stay on Carurystal. She cast enhanced

detect magic and saw ribbons of power wrapping around everything. She grabbed one, located quite far from the Avatar, and entering it, she looked into the entire network stretching around Brightmoon and traced the path leading to the moonstone... Then she dug the claws of her self into the ancient creation of The First Ones and brutally tore the thread from it and dragged it to her daughter. She wrapped a ribbon of power around her, partially soothing her torment. However, this was only a partial solution. In the case of the Black Garnet, she used complex machinery to maintain the connection, but even then it eventually broke and she had to renew it regularly or she would begin to die... In this case, it was only possible because the Arrival of the Light Eater had severed the magical network around the runestone. , but this state would not last long, especially since the Moonstone already had its owner, but a plan was already starting to form in her head... But then the guards burst in. The Devourer of Light was already disappearing into the dimensional rift , but what was still visible was there to stop them, but only for a moment. When the Avatar disappeared, they looked at them as if they had just realized that Shadow Weaver was out of the cell and that the girl they had let in was gone, replaced by a strange creature all too similar to the Dark Sorceress. One of them, a stocky woman, gripped her halberd tighter and called out.

„Stand where you are... Don't move, or ... otherwise... „ She directed her halberd towards them, with electric sparks dancing at the end of it.

„Listen to me, I'll go back to the cell, but you take this girl to Lady... „ The guard didn't let her finish, because when he saw that she was trying to get up, he screamed.

„I told you not to move.” he came closer, threatening her with his weapon. Then Nightgale raised her hand and released a stream of white flame that enveloped both guards, leaving them smoldering, blackened remains. The heat was so great that it burned the door and melted the stone. So much for peaceful solutions...

„ I'm not very good at teleportation magic mother, but you probably know her... „ the girl groaned, her body still flooded with waves of pain.

„ Yes, but first we need to find Lady Cala... She can help you, or rather a certain item in her possession. – she said, helping her daughter get up

Chapter End Notes

This was probably one of the darker and sadder chapters, wasn't it? What do you think about it?

Nothing ends with a simple yea or nay

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She would rather go to sleep. She cuddled up to Bow and fell asleep in his arms, forgetting all the events of the day. And she slept until noon and then ate breakfast in bed, or rather dinner... And then she took a hot bath and slept some more, and then maybe she went on her honeymoon... And she would probably do all this, except for going to honeymoon, she could wait until things cleared up, until they released Entrapta and Catra's sister, and then they could move on to other matters... But before she went to bed, she would have to do a few more things... But first, she needed to eat something and talk to Catra. She had pretty much had enough conversations for today, the last two made everything even more confusing. Her feline friend was nervous, which really shouldn't have surprised her. Both Shadow Weaver and Lady Cala addressed Catra's painful past, reopening old wounds, although in the case of the Inhuman aristocrat, no one expected her to be connected to her friend's origins. The Grand Marshal had always been sensitive, and the mere mention of the dark Sorceress put her in a dark mood. Now meeting the dark Sorceress again could awaken that old darkness. She was worried about this, but at the same time she wanted to trust her. This wasn't the old Catra after all. She had Adora, her beloved, and them, her faithful friends. You can always count on their support…

But he also has a father now. There's no telling which direction this man will push her... she thought, grimacing. She didn't like the Lord Admiral, she was completely sure of that now. Of course, as a queen, she often had to cooperate with people she didn't like. The problem was that she didn't trust Antares at all, she already knew that this man wanted something much more than he was telling them all... He wanted power, she was sure of that now... He had appointed himself Lord Protector... He claimed it was his appointment given to him by local government, but she

wasn't stupid … She knew that no one would say no to someone like him on Taurus… He had an Army and a Navy, after all, but he had also come to liberate them from the clutches of Horde Prime's loyalists… They really should have gotten there sooner… Perhaps they had become too complacent… They enjoyed the privilege of freedom, completely forgetting that others could only dream about it... That's why she couldn't completely break off cooperation with this person... And there were Lady Calia's words... As soon as she thought about them, a shiver ran down her spine.

She moved them to the family dining room, the smaller one where she sometimes ate with her mother... It could only accommodate ten people at most, so the conditions were practically intimate. Adora slumped in her chair, deep in thought, and Catra paced around the room, nervously wagging her tail. Yes, she will have to talk to her. Soon, however, Bow arrived and, together with Mermista, brought them... Dinner? She wasn't sure what to call this meal. It was dark outside the windows... Almost 24 hours had passed since those terrible night events. It felt like it had been a whole week and simultaneously like everything had just happened a moment ago. Bow was a good cook, and Mermista was the best cook of them all, which she said was because she was sometimes afraid to let Seahawk into the fire. She took a few lessons from her herself. They got a few slices of bread dipped in egg, a cream of red vegetables with croutons made of rye bread, and pancakes stuffed with meat and seafood, as well as scrambled eggs with vegetables. The sight alone brought a wide smile to her face. She grabbed a slice of buttered bread and poured herself some soup. As soon as Adora saw the food, she immediately perked up and helped herself to a huge portion of scrambled eggs. Catra sat down on a chair and grabbed the cake and began to devour it hungrily.

„It's delicious! Did you cook it?” The Grand Marshal asked Mermista, who smiled weakly.

„It's an old family recipe... I had to do something to ... not to think about what happened.” said the ruler of Salinea. Everyone

knew what worried her so much. For a while everyone ate in silence until Bow, who sat next to her, asked.

„What was she like... Shadow Weaver... Did she say anything?”

When the name of the dark Sorceress was spoken, Catra bristled and growled angrily.

„She's the same mean bitch as always, and she only told lies... Nothing has changed!” As she said this, Melog turned burgundy from her anger

„No... She's broken.” she said quietly, and everyone looked at her in surprise, and she sighed and started explaining to her friends

„When she was with us as a prisoner, she always tried to exude authority and strength, to let everyone know that even though she was imprisoned, she still controlled the situation. That's how it was when my mother imprisoned her... She mocked and tried to outsmart everyone... Do you remember Adora... It was you she was talking to then...„ She looked at the blonde-haired warrior, who nodded and said-

„I remember well what it was like back then... she... She was arrogant... She wanted to seem strong, tried to shock us, but finally humbled herself when it seemed like she was dying.” she looked at Catra, who flattened her ears. She understood that talking about those moments must have been difficult for her, because while the Dark Sorceress was seeking refuge in Brightmoon, she was waiting in a cell to be send to Beast Island after being betrayed Shadow weaver. The Grand Marshal, however, nodded to her wife as a sign that she could continue. – It was different now… She was as humble as ever… As if she really felt guilty… And he didn't hide his face. She always got angry when someone saw her without a mask... This time she acted like she didn't care... No, she wanted us to look into her face, see her as she really was. You're right Glimmer... Something broke her...

„It was death.” she whispered in sudden understanding. “She died and then came back... We know these things happen... Do you remember Catra, how you told us about that creature you fought in the depths of Mystacor? And then there's Lady Sorrowflame and the others, if I understood your father's words correctly... Maybe she's something like that... „ she said thoughtfully, but Catra grimaced.

„I would sense it if she was non-dead I recognized that Lady Cala is a damn monster, we can also check it with the example of Lady Sorrowflame... She probably didn't go away with my father... No, she's alive... „ the cat girl stretched out her claws furiously and dug them into the table top and then added. „ For now…” A nasty smile appeared on Catra's face, but Melog lowered his ears.

She refrained from giving her friend a concerned look, but it was words like these that worried her. Shadow Weaver brought out the worst in people.

"It's not only death, but also life..." Bow interjected. “You said that according to your father, she was a well-respected resident of Lady Cala's home planet. She lived there among those who did not even suspect who she was.”

She smiled at her… Husband and nodded slowly.

„Archduke Adamson told me the same thing... Both she and Lady Cala were liked by the citizens of Carurystal and no one even suspected that they could be such... people.” she explained, looking at her friends.

„She's always been good at pretending to be better than she is. She was able to… put on a mask of kindness and nobility.| Adora said firmly, also digging her fingers into the table top. „ I know something about this!”

„What I mean is that how we live... How others perceive us changes us.” Bow looked at Catra, who snorted in irritation.

„Besides, she feels better now than before. Someone healed her much more than Adora. This could have changed her.” she explained what she had been thinking about for some time.

„She's manipulating you again, Glimmer!” Catra growled, getting up from her chair. „You don't remember how she sent your father to Beast Island. How she tricked you into abandoning Entrapta and almost destroying Etheria.”

„I have to remind you who sent Entrapta to the Island and who pushed us to the wall that we had to resort to such measures.” Mermiasta suddenly interjected. Catra looked at her gloomily, but the ruler of Salinea shook her head and closed her eyes, and then said. “I shouldn't have said that, I'm sorry, but I'm just so tired... Everything that happened... I'm worried about Frosta and what I did to her... I'm as guilty as Shadow Weaver for what happened to her... That terrible woman... You know, those who live with the Sea... We don't see the world in as bright colors as you do. For us, it is not filled with the rustle of leaves and the chirping of birds. Even at the surface, the sea is angry and stormy... And its deeps... It is a cold, dark abyss hostile to all life... But even there, you can discover beauty... I tell you this so that you can understand certain things. We don't see the world as simply as you do... We have stories of an ancient city stretching at the bottom of every sea and none... There lives an ancient ruler who is neither dead nor alive but dreams dreams that haunt those with wounded or sensitive souls ... He can be harsh and kind, he sends earthquakes and abundant catches ... He is truly like the Sea itself ... Sailors worship him because they know that if they lose sight of the shore, they will only be at his mercy. Although he may be ruthless, he protects its rights... Sometimes it also shows mercy... It sometimes gives back those it took away so that they can take revenge... or atone for their sins. I don't know if that's the case in space, but maybe...” concluded the ruler of Salinea thoughtfully, but Catra then banged her fists on the table and screamed.

„Are you guys crazy?! Listen to yourselves, what you say. This bitch has barely arrived here and you're already wondering if she should escape the punishment she deserves for what she did to

us... To all of us! You need to get her out of here as soon as possible, because she's already starting to have a hold on you! „ Gold and blue flames burned in the Catwoman's heterochromatic eyes Melog also glowed multi-colored, as if he was overwhelmed by the emotions raging in his companion's soul....

„Do you really want to give her to Halo and her sister?" she asked her friend in disbelief, who nodded vigorously and spoke with fierce anger.

„Yes, apparently we need to take her away, because she makes you lose your mind..." Melog cringed under hers wrath.

It is unknown how this discussion would go further, because a few angry words nearly escaped her lips when Scorpia entered the room where they were conferring with the Child of Entrapta and Hordak in her arms.

„Frosta woke up and would like to talk to you!" she exclaimed joyfully at the top of her voice and the gloomy, angry atmosphere in the room immediately dissipated.

„It's great!" Adora exclaimed, beaming with pure joy.

„You don't even know how happy we all are. "Catra wiped a tear from her cheek and Melog howled happily.

„I... I can't... I just can't...„ Mermista was saying, but Scorpia waved her pincers.

„Come on, Misty! Frosta has no grudge against you!" exclaimed the former Horde officer. However, she felt a strange, indescribable anxiety.

„Is Frosta okay?" she asked carefully, and Scorpia hesitated. She was even worse at hiding the truth than Entrapta...

„Yes...Absolutely, everything is fine...Almost...Actually... „ said the ruler of the Scorpions, and the Child started playing with Bow.

„I'll take care of him. I need to get more practice taking care of children...„ said her husband. Mermista gave her a surprised and slightly mocking look, she would now tease her for not letting her fight, even though she was also there for hope. She smiled at her friend, but then immediately became serious and sighed full of bad feelings and then teleported all her friends.

Frosta looked healthy. She was pale and her eyes had dark circles, but after what had happened to her, she seemed to be doing quite well... Although she wasn't sure what exactly had happened to her... She knew almost nothing about dark magic, and to tell the truth, she didn't want any more. know. Maybe she should have asked Shadow Weaver what spell she used back then, or sought her father's advice... But the girl seemed to be fine ... because everything was fine, right?

Frosta was happy, to a fault... No one is that happy right after a brush with death, unless they want to hide how bad they really are... She couldn't see anything specific yet... The ice princess seemed to be feeling fine, but she noticed that Scorpia feels strangely tense, and out of the corner of her eye she saw Perfuma whispering something to the insectoid, one of those Shirren, luckily it wasn't the annoying Ashurk, but another representative of this People. He looked older, though in such creatures it was hard to say how true that was. He wore long emerald robes, so at first she thought he was a Sorcerer, but something about his posture told her he wasn't. He must have been one of those priests of Eridani... She frowned. She didn't trust them, there was something about them that reminded them of the Galactic Horde. So she didn't like the fact that the ruler of Plumeria was hanging out with someone like that, especially when it was necessary to keep an eye on Frosta's condition... The ice princess listened carefully to the story about the night fight with the giant monster, she had already heard it from Scorpia and Perfuma, but she had the impression that they both didn’t tell her everything rather carefully. She felt sorry for Adora that Lady Cala tried to kill her, but the truth about the blonde-haired aristocrat didn't shock

Frosta like the others, but that wasn't surprising, after all, she had never spoken to this treacherous woman. The Ice Princess asked the most questions about Lonnie and her companions, especially a red-haired girl named Scarlet, who was supposedly the Comrade General right hand and a Sorcerer. She remembered that she, Catra and the others had clashed with them in some lost city. The Ice Princess apparently spent many hours together with Scarlet trapped underground, and they probably saved each other's lives several times, such events can bring people together, she knew something about it. What was even sadder was that Scarlet was largely responsible for what happened to Frosta... However, it seemed that the Ice Princess had no grudge against Scarlet for what happened to her. She didn't blame Mermista either, which made the Sea Lady a little relieved, but not as much as one might expect …. After everyone told her what happened, Adora joked.

„I didn't know our adventures were so exciting that they make you hyperventilate!" The Princess of Power laughed warmly, although Frosta was actually breathing faster and deeper than people usually did...

„I'm breathing normally! As always! Don't talk nonsense Adora!" Frosta exclaimed, her voice indignant, but above all, scared. Everyone looked at her confused. But Adora smiled understandingly.

„Of course you're breathing normally, I just made a stupid joke.„ she said and put her hand on her shoulder... Then Frosta pulled away from her as if she had been scalded and crouched down, and this strange companion of Frosta, who had been lying at her feet until now, covered the ice princess and started hissing at Adora, who moved away confused.

„ I... I'm sorry, I didn't know I would do something to you... I didn't think you were still so sore... „ said the Heroine of the Galaxy, and tears began to flow down the Ice Princess's face, leaving strange gray streaks on her cheeks. Catra moved towards her to wipe them, but as she was about to touch her face, she stepped back and wrinkled her nose, Melog backed away,

growling softly. The feline woman looked around at everyone, clearly shocked. She and her wife looked at her expectantly, as if she should know what was happening to their friend. In a way, it was true, she was an expert in magic... She should be able to help Frosta, just like she was able to help her father... She sighed, because in fact they were right and cast a few spells revealing the truth and looked at the Ice Princess, and then she had a hard time restraining herself from letting out a scream. Threads of Darkness wrapped around Frosta, reaching towards her heart and penetrating her most important points connecting her spiritual essence with her body. Seeing her reaction, Catra and Adora paled in understandable fear. She motioned for them and Mermista to come to her, and she went out into the corridor to talk to them, although she didn't know what to say at all. To her surprise, Perfume and that Insectoid in Emerald robes.

„And what's wrong with her? Do you know how to get this cold out of her?” Adora asked with desperate hope in her voice.

„I'm not sure, I've never encountered anything like this, I'd have to look for information in Mystacor or from Bow's dads... It's a pity that my dad and Aunt Casta are not here. It will take some time though, maybe he can arrange help from other Sorceress if necessary.” she said, fully aware that this was not the answer they expected from her.

„What did you sense from Frosta... You and Melog?„ Perfume asked Catra and her companion.

„It was... Something similar to what I felt from Lady Cala, though stronger here than the creature's here, though not as repulsive. I thought it smelled like death... If it's death magic, we really should go to Lady Sorrowflame for help.” asked the Grand Marshal carefully. The mere mention of the Lord Admiral's monstrous engineer made her flinch.

„If I may interject.” the insectoid's voice echoed in their heads, causing Catra to jump and growl angrily.

„You already did it!”

The newcomer, undeterred, continued on.

„I am Reverend Zimach and I helped Princess Perfume rescue Princess Frosta from the Black Dream... She met two beings there... One was strange and extremely alien, but the Other... It was Charon, the Rider of Death and the undisputed leader of the Daemons of Abbadon. „ He fell silent, but Catra asked suspiciously.

„Is he a real Sorcerer or some imaginary one like Iomdi and the rest?” she heard a lot of anger and contempt in her voice.

„Does he wear a Black Hat and sail a boat on the Black River?„ Adora asked with fear in her voice. When Zimach confirmed her words, she turned pale and added, „ He is Real... I met him Catra... In a dream, when I was on Icarus... He was there, and this Second Being... The one from this book, about whom Shadow Weaver spoke... It was Charon who warned me that you were in danger, and that's why I wound up on Etheria…”

Zimach moved his antennae in a strange way, she got the impression that he was concerned.

„This is very bad, really very bad... I'm afraid Princess Frosta is turning into some kind of undead. Maybe she is a Dhampir, or something like the Gray Gardeners of Galt on Lost Golarion... A being neither completely alive nor dead... I can't say much more after such a short inspection, nor am I an expert in necromancy. Perhaps Lady Sorrowflame would be able to help, but... to put it mildly, she is not known for her good approach to patients...”

There was a gloomy silence. Everyone looked at each other in fear... It wasn't the news they were ready for, but could you be ready to hear that you had to stand idly by and watch your friend turn into a creature straight from a scary campfire story... They were powerless... But they had to do something … They just had to… Catra was the first to break the silence.

„We can't give up... There has to be some way to stop this... To reverse this... Surely there are Sh-Ra's powers that can help. Maybe if we search the Mystacor library or others. You are the most powerful sorceress on Etheri, you must be able to do something. – the cat's eyes were shining feverishly. – I can talk to Shadow Weaver… In an appropriate way… I know ways to get her to tell us everything…

She looked at Catra with horror…

„You don't say that you would be able to... That you would did it... on her.” asked the Grand Marshal, who smiled in a very ugly way.

„To Shadow Weaver, to help Frost...„ she replied in a hard tone that was more dark than she had heard from her in the last five years... They stared at each other for a moment until Adora spoke up.

„Is there a way to contact Charon or other beings like him? Maybe we'll be able to convince him to leave Frosta alone, or maybe others will be able to help her?”

Zimach thought about what she said for a moment, and then he said.

„Yes, it is possible, although very difficult, but you are She-Ra, you are much closer to the gods than anyone else, so it may be much easier for you.” she could feel the cautious hope in his voice echoing in their heads. Adora nodded uncertainly, but Catra first turned pale, then turned beet red.

„You don't really want to listen to someone like that! We cannot contact such… people.” she said, her voice full of rage, but she had the impression that she also heard fear in it. Then she walked up to Shirren and put her claw to his chest.

„And you should leave my wife alone! It's all you fault! I'm sure you're responsible for what happened to Frosta and as soon as I get the evidence.” the Grand Marshal drawled.

„Catra, Zimach helped me a lot when we were trying to save Frosta, and I assure you that he did not mean to hurt her in any way! – Perfuma exclaims, truly outraged. Catra was about to say something not so nice to her, but then something shook the entire Brightmoon and she felt a new power appear in her castle. She was powerful and terrible... It was pure evil, similar to the one she had sensed from the creature she had recently fought, but much... deeper and at the same time more distant. It was like comparing the darkness in a cavernous cave to the dark shadow of space. Perfume also felt it, she let out a strangled cry and doubled over... Her wife immediately ran out of Frosty's room.

„Honey, flower, how can I help you!” exclaimed the ruler of the Scorpions, hugging her beloved.

„Someone in the castle has summoned something, something terrible... A very great evil. " cried Zimah, cringing. He also felt that something very bad was happening here.

„Can you tell where it is?” Adora asked, she was in better condition than the three of them. She shook her head.

„Not now, it's like it's spread all over Brightmoon, maybe if I focus... „ she groaned and then suddenly felt something tugging at the entire magical web. Throughout the hospital wing, doctors and healers began running around the rooms as if checking them.

„That thing... It drained all the magic, destroyed all the spells we had kept... „ she groaned. Her friends looked at her in confusion, and then understanding dawned on Catra's face.

„Shadow Weaver. She did it to free herself!” she exclaimed. Claws emerged from her back. This time, the encounter with Shadow Weaver will not end only with stunning...

„I... I can help!” Frosta suddenly called out, running out of her room still wearing her hospital pajamas. They looked at her in amazement.

„Frosta, now is not the time to show how strong you are.” she said, feeling a bit more confident than before.

„I'm fine! I can handle it!” the Ice Princess shouted, and Shogi standing next to her, now in the form of a large cat, barked to support her words. She sighed, having absolutely no idea what she should do in this situation. The girl looked healthy at that moment, apart from the obviously pale complexion, but on the other hand, she was not that well, now with her magical sense she sensed a strange, difficult to detect, but still present resonance, similar to the one emanating from Lady Sorrowflame, although of course much weaker. But they couldn't keep her locked up all the time, they wouldn't lock her up in the hospital wing for the rest of her... life? She shuddered at the thought... Frosta must have noticed that he was staring at her a little too long, because there was so much despair and pain on her face... She couldn't bear to look at it...

„Okay, Frosta, you can come with us.„ she managed to be friendly, although she felt like crying over the fate of the girl who treated her like an older sister. She was already shaking hands with her friends to teleport them, when suddenly she felt a sharp tug that almost tore her soul away. And then an overwhelming cold enveloped her. She felt that she was losing strength... She felt nauseous, her legs gave way under her...

„Adora, someone has taken the Moonstone!„ she exclaimed and began to fall into the darkness... Before she lost consciousness, she heard Catra saying, "Damn, sorcerous female dog."

Chapter End Notes

> As you can see, Shadow Weaver can do a lot of harm even unintentionally.

And warriors don't die for nothing...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

And warriors don't die for nothing...

Calamity and Blackwind became bane…. A reminder to the wretched Mortal beings of what the order of things really was like ... That they were always just vermin allowed to sully the beauty of this world simply because they were unworthy of the attention of the true Masters of the Universe... Though that wasn't entirely true... Mortals could be quite useful, and they provided a lot of fun!...

She walked ahead, through the wide corridors of Brightmoon , so grand and beautiful that could have been hers... If there was even a shred of justice in this lousy world... But maybe this will change, after all, this world belongs to those who are strong enough to take into your own hands the threads of destiny. Calamity was strong, her will was unparalleled, and her heart was as pure and hard as the most perfect diamond... She was perfection incarnate and anyone who did not bow down to her fully deserved the worst possible end.

The servants did not immediately run away when they saw her. Many of them stopped in surprise, some even looked concerned, they clearly felt sorry for the woman in the torn dress and wildly disheveled hair, maybe they even thought that some misfortune had befallen her. The smarter ones ran away when they saw her smile or looked into her eyes, and the rest ran away, screaming when they saw Blackwind following her. She didn't chase them, it was the correct thing to do when seeing an angry being of her kind, or when encountering a creature as wonderful as her mount.

Klementine walked between them, trying to remain calm, although she could see that it was not easy for someone like her. She had to admit, however, that the locals knew how to behave in a dangerous situation, and these thirty years of war had taught them a thing or two, at least Shadow Weaver wasn't making this up when she said that the inhabitants of this planet were tough. The first guard to confront her died instantly when she grabbed him by the throat and snapped his neck. However, his companion did not resist her, but raised the alarm and retreated. This was a major inconvenience, she had lost her chance to get out of here undetected. She had no specific plan, except that she was to get a vehicle and escape from here, and then seek shelter in one of the cultists' cells who would help her hide so that she could continue her great mission, but first she had to get out of here, and it wasn't that easy. The biggest problem was She-Ra, she was very afraid of facing her, she had to admit it to herself. The usurper had the power to kill her, it was hard to imagine a more terrible eventuality. But she wasn't the only problem. This sparkling whore could have easily grabbed her unexpectedly and taken her to a place from which she couldn't escape this time... She had to be on her guard... Because evil could come from anywhere.

A moment after the Alarm was raised, she felt something. It was the presence of…His…Their presence! They came here! Creeping Chaos! She didn't recognize this Face, but that wasn't important, after all, no one knew all of them. But they came here in person! Their presence filled her body with ecstasy. Even though she was not a magic user, she felt that this creature was tugging at the entire magical network, this power was beyond imagination! She fell to her knees, her body contorting as she experienced the splendor of the Great Outer God…

„Lady Calo! What happened!” Klementine exclaimed in fear. If she knew who had visited this wretched planet, she would howl with horror and delight. After a while, however, the presence disappeared as suddenly as it appeared. It really shouldn't have surprised her, after all, there were few places in the universe that could withstand the glory of someone so amazing without

breaking like a shattered glass ball, but she still felt disappointed. Someone had to summon the Avatar of Nyarlathotep , which actually wasn't that difficult, the problem was always controlling them, or maybe rather begging them to do what was wanted of them, it was a matter of interpretation. Only who on this planet abandoned by the gods would know how to summon such a wonderful creature... She only knew one thing...

"Take me to the place where Shadow Weaver is being held," she ordered Klementina in a hard voice that brooked no objections.

They ran ahead, although not as fast as she would have liked, because Frosta had to keep up with them, and even Scorpia, although she made huge leaps, quickly became out of breath, this exoskeleton weighed its weight... However, she had to admit that the Ice Princess was in surprisingly good shape, considering she was in a coma not too long ago. Zimah 's words rang in the back of her head , but they were nonsense! Frosta has always been a strong and tough girl who was not afraid of the icy wastes of her homeland. Nothing happened to her, and these strange symptoms were a remnant of the Shadow Weaver's spells, nothing more! This will all pass once Frosta gets some rest! And if not, he would rip the way to heal her from Shadow Weaver's throat, Even if it was the last thing she ever said... And she wouldn't regret it, maybe last time instead of catching her, she should have ended her vile life .

They arrived at a guardhouse that had been converted into a temporary command post, where Brother Blade and General Juliette were waiting for them .

„How she escaped! Where is now?” she asked in a sharp tone.

„What are you talking about?” replied the General. She was furious, but also scared. “Lady Cala escaped by kidnapping my daughter, and Shadow Weaver… I'm not sure. I haven't heard from the guards who were supposed to keep an eye on her.”

Juliette said , she seemed irritated that she had to explain to them what was happening. “Didn't you hear the Alarm?”

„No, we found out about everything after Glimmer and Perfuma felt and all the spells stopped working, and then the Queen was cut off from her stone!” she explained, barely restraining her outburst of rage, because she felt that she was wasting her time explaining to everyone what had happened.

„It must be a coordinated action, they must have had a plan for a long time what to do in case of imprisonment...„ Adora said in a confident voice, she herself would probably have prepared an escape plan long before she arrived at the enemy's headquarters. “Do you know how she broke the spell without being detected?” she asked at the end, but the general shook her head, looking at her incomprehension, so the Princess of Power added. "It must have been some kind of ritual, and I don't believe Glimmer didn't leave anything behind that would alert us to the fact that she was trying to cast such a powerful spell. I don't know how she escaped detection.”

„Has anyone visited Shadow Weaver?” Mermista asked with a thoughtful face. The general nodded.

„I think Nightgale came to her to perform spells, apparently on the queen's orders.” explained the General. Now everything was clear, she didn't like this woman from the beginning. But before she could voice her suspicions, Frosta shouted.

„Is Nightgale here?”

Everyone looked at the Ice Princess, the general made a face as if she had just noticed her.

„Well, yes, she's Castaspela's assistant, although apparently she recently went to visit relatives, but she came back...„ she explained to her friend, smiling grimly, but Frosta shook her head vigorously and called out.

„I do not understand you! Scarlet is Nightgale!

„Nightgale is Scarlet? That would explain a lot why Lonnie was so aware of our activities.” she said, remembering her own trick involving Double Trouble, but Frosta shook her head again

„No... It's the other way around... Nightgale is Scarlet.” The Ice Princess hesitated for a moment. – She is her daughter!

She snorted when she heard the girl's words.

„She wasn't a mother to any of the cadets, not even to us.”

„NO! She... She is the Daughter of Shadow Weaver and Hordak .” the Ice Princess exclaimed with a pained expression on her face. It took them a long time to absorb the incredible news Frosta had given them.

„But how... When...„ she gasped, still in shock...

„Do we really want to know how it went...„ Mermista said, her face turning green.

„Entrapta always said that Hordak's Heart was full of love... But, for Shadow Weaver...!?„ Scorpia said, and Perfuma became lost in thought.

„It didn't happen that way... She was created when Catra was exiled... But after what happened during the portal story, Hordak banished her...„ she looked down, saddened... „I didn't tell you about it because Nightgale she didn't want to... Even Lonnie doesn't know the truth... She's very afraid, she's afraid that you will reject her for who she is... „

It wasn't the knowledge she was ready for, although it didn't shock her as much as it should have. Now everything was falling into place logically.

„Shadow Weaver was always able to say what others wanted to hear. She probably said a few nice words to her daughter and thus gained the perfect supporter.” she said quietly. She didn't know what to think about the fact that the woman she hated so much

had a child... She didn't know this Scarlet... Or rather Nightgale ... Should she judge her through the prism of her mother? Horde Prime was such a terrible monster that it was hard to put into words, but most of his clones were good and nice people, just look at Brother Blade. Her Uncle wasn't a good person either, and she herself was raised by Shadow Weaver... But that wicked woman had marked her as well... This young sorceress was spying on them, hiding among them, serving Lonnie, but was she really? If Lonnie didn't know her true identity... Maybe it wasn't Comrade General who she really Served. Could this be the same terrible and mysterious creature that Shadow Weaver served? So many questions and so few clues...

„I'm sorry, but could you please stop discussing the origins of this damn sorceress and focus on rescuing my daughter from the clutches of the fucking monster!" the General growled Juliette , and Brother Blade nodded and added.

„In fact, time is running out. We must do something as soon as possible to stop these women, because if they escape, the whole of Etheria will be in danger... „ there was absolute seriousness in the clone's voice, he seriously meant what he said. Adora nodded and asked for the castle plans, then when one of the guards handed them to her, she looked at them for a moment and finally said.

„They will definitely want to meet before they run away... Cala will already know the castle well enough, and Shadow Weaver knows it well from her previous stay here, and besides, she has Nightgale ... This is where they will meet... „ she pointed to a point on the map.

„It's near her old garden... You know, I never believed in fate and things like that... But there will be a beautiful irony in what will happen there." she said with a menacing smile, baring her fangs.

Lady Ka didn't blame the Lord Admiral for what happened. After thinking about it, she even decided that she had gotten away with it. If Antares had found out under different circumstances that she had declawed the kitten, it could have been much worse than losing a few fingers. She was immune to pain, her father taught her what real suffering was. The Lord Admiral destroyed his enemies ruthlessly, but was lenient towards his subjects who let him down . He figured cutting off a few of her fingers would do the trick, and honestly, so did it. Nowadays, even the loss of an entire limb was not a tragedy... There were many people who voluntarily replaced biological body parts with cybernetic implants, so as not to have to look far, Graag replaced his leg, the knee of which was shot through, with a mechanical prosthesis and he intended to do the same with the hand he injured in the last fight? Maybe she should follow his example and replace her own hand? Then she will get new, beautiful claws.

She had no grudge against this shadowy witch, after all, in war and politics, anything goes. They were adversaries, or maybe just rivals, and honestly she wasn't sure what their status was, so it was understandable that they tried to hurt each other as much as they could. Therefore, at the first opportunity he will try to cut off her hand or two, just for the sake of it... Or maybe not, she'll see... Revenge is pleasant, but in this case it was definitely not a priority ... She had to think about completing the mission for Antares ... And about securing her future, because perhaps her days at the Lord Admiral's side are numbered... Although if it's true and She-Ra can heal Antares ... Sometimes the future unfolds in truly unbelievable ways...

Suddenly she heard footsteps, the corridors of the castle were strangely deserted, perhaps she had noticed it before, but her mental acuity was dulled by the painkillers she had to take anyway. She hid in the shadows behind the tapestry and watched. First she saw a woman... It was Lady Cala, now almost naked, for her dress was in tatters and what was left was stained with blood. She also took on her more monstrous form, as she extended her claws and a bone blade from her forearm, and her eye was purple-purple , but she was still damn sexy, or maybe that's why...

Behind her was a tall elf with a swarthy complexion who looked like she was about to fall. into hysteria. She seemed as charming as she was completely incapable of surviving in the real world… Her world. And behind them walked a large creature. It was all black, darker than the night, it actually absorbed the light. It was the size of a huge horse, whose silhouette it resembled. Its muzzle ended in a beak made of black iron The legs were thick, spread wide, ending in double hooves that left black, hissing marks wherever they touched. It had wide webbed wings, equipped with single claws that seemed sharp like swords. His eyes would be deep purple , as if they were gates to another, terrible world... He was beautiful. Pushed by the impulse, she emerged from behind the tapestry and waved to the trio as they passed by. Lady Cala raised an eyebrow at her, to which she responded with an exaggerated bow and said.

„I'm just passing by and admiring your majesty."

Lady Cala smiled

„May luck favor you, noble wanderer." she said and bowed in a much more appropriate way. Then each of them went their own way. Lady. Ka decided that now it would be wiser to slip away unnoticed, because the events that Lady Cala would probably lead to would be remembered for a long time and it would be better if she was not associated with them. As she walked to the quarters reserved for her soldiers, she thought about what had happened and came to the conclusion that a completely new path had just opened up to her, leading to an unknown future... Maybe she would enter it... If Lady Cala succeeded... But Life has taught her that monsters always win...

She walked shrouded in darkness, her daughter following behind her. The girl walked straight, but there was pain on her face, as if her very soul was on fire. In fact, that was the case, she remembered well, as magic flowed through her veins like a rushing river, a sense of omnipotence with the simultaneous

awareness of impending doom. It was wonderful and terrifying at the same time. Ecstasy and pain pierced through her body. Now she realized that all her life she had wanted to experience this moment again, to return to the moment of her first fall. Everything she did after that was in fact an attempt to return to that moment, or to escape from the terror that was reaching out for her... Then she sealed her fate. So now, as she looked at Nightgale, she couldn't help but think that her daughter would also lose the chance to shape her future.

To her surprise, no one tried to stop them, although she was sure that an alarm had been raised. Now she only hoped that she could find Lady Cala before Adora and the others found her... She knew that Catra was furious with her, and trying to escape would only increase her anger, so this time her former ward might have no qualms about ending it this time. her sinful life... Only that Nightgale will defend her, and with her power... With a bit of luck, or rather misfortune, she is able to harm even She-Ra... The thought that her children, both the adopted and scorned ones, as well as this, whose existence she had only recently learned about, they would fight each other was more terrifying than the prospect of meeting Nyarlathotep again . But there was nothing she could do about it...

They reached an intersection, but then she saw several guards trying to stop her. They were accompanied by several bots of the former Etherian Horde. The guards kept their distance, hiding behind the machines. They didn't seem eager to fight, and she quickly figured their goal was only to slow her down without risking her life too much. She withdrew her tentacles a little, then called out.

„No one has to get hurt... Just let us pass.” she tried to keep her voice calm but firm.

„We have received orders to stop you and we will do it even at the cost of our lives!„ exclaimed the commander of the guards in a trembling voice. Judging by her accent, she must have once

served in the Horde, so standing in front of the one she had been afraid of almost all her life required special courage...

„It's quite a high price and as far as I know Glimmer, she wouldn't ask her soldiers to pay it, your queen is not me... You are probably supposed to buy some time for her and the princesses, which you did, so please leave.” she said truthfully. She wasted a lot of time trying to resolve the situation peacefully ... It would have been better for them to have flooded them with a storm of spells without a word, Nightgale was seething with the desire to unleash the power seething in her heart. Perhaps the guard would have succumbed to the power of persuasion and ordered her subordinates to retreat, but then death came from the adjacent corridor.

Lady Cala rushed out at the gathered guards in her semi-monstrous form, laughing gleefully as she took life. Behind her came a beast straight from nightmares, a creature that mocked all that was sublime and beautiful. Somehow, Lady Cala summoned her mount from distant Carurystal. She had never seen his true form before, but she had no trouble figuring out what this monster was. The unfortunate warriors were so absorbed in their conversation with the dark Sorceress that they did not even notice the approaching Doom. Nightale, filled with power and pain, jumped into the fight, throwing a magic missile at the nearest warrior , an officer who had once belonged to the Horde, and then struck two more guardsmen with lightning that shot from her fingers. She herself did not join the fight, even if she wanted to, she would not have had time to do anything, because the fight did not last even ten heartbeats... When it was all over, Lady Cala, who had not even been out of breath during the fight, looked at her daughter . She was already waiting for the malicious, contemptuous comment that would provoke her daughter to magically attack Yog-Sototh 's spawn , partly even waiting for it because perhaps Nightgale would rid the world of this vile creature. But her ward bowed to the younger sorceress and said without mockery in her voice.

„I knew you were hiding the Great Secret Nightgale , No wonder our lord chose you as his servant.”

The meaning of those words hit her like a war hammer... Her daughter served the Creeping Chaos... It explained so much... She knew that this strange Elf with sparkling skin was connected to Nyarlathotep, but she wasn't sure if she served him... After all, she was marked by the Great One. The Outer God, but for decades she had served only herself... Now her daughter had fallen into his trap, and there was no way to free herself from them , she knew it... But she couldn't afford to let this dark revelation break her. She had to act for the good of her daughter.

„We have to hurry, someone will reach us soon, because these soldiers were only here to stop us.” she said, glancing at the bloodstone ring resting on Lady Cala's hand. She looked around. Next to Lady Cala and her nightmare companion stood a girl who looked like she was just one step away from a nervous breakdown... Off to the side was a terrace with a garden ... her garden from the time she was in so-called captivity with Glimmer. He has gone wild over the years, or maybe he was allowed to go wild...

„There is!” she heard Adora exclaim. Well, these warriors didn't die for nothing after all...

I came too late, she thought, seeing the carnage that had taken place. If she had come here faster, if she hadn't wasted time on unnecessary discussions ... When she had taken the form of She a little earlier, or if she had known her teleportation powers better ... If... There were so many things she could have done better, but she failed. All she could do now was capture her adoptive mother and the wicked aristocrat... Capture... was this really the best solution? Catra would have a different opinion... She looked at her wife who was running next to her with cold fury on her face.

„Promise you won't do anything to Nightgale , okay?” Frosta asked with pleading in her eyes.

„We'll try... „ she said. She recognized this woman from a distance. Before, Nightgale hadn't caught her attention, maybe only because of her height, but now that she showed her true colors... She saw an obvious resemblance to their adoptive mother, but she also resembled one of the clones, but it wasn't her appearance that made her feel uneasy when she was looking at her, but she felt something from her. She simply burned with darkness, something similar emanated from Shadow Weaver, but in her case it was much stronger, like comparing a glowing ember to the flame of a fire pit. There was something unatural about that power, like Lady Cala's smile.

However, what terrified her the most was the creature standing next to the terrible aristocrat. She looked like someone had taken Swiftwind and fed it nightmares and hatred. As soon as the monster saw her, it vomited purple flame, but she dodged it, so it hissed so loudly that she felt as if the sound would burst her head. Shadow Weaver then created a pool of darkness in front of them , from which numerous tentacles shot out and grabbed their legs and arms, although the grip wasn't crushing, it slowed them down for a moment, Catra and Melog jumped over them, but then Nightgale cast a spell that made them that her wife's body was twisted in pain, as was her companion, so she roared, feeling the fear and anger pierce her soul, and summoned a bright light that dispersed the shadowy tendrils, and then she charged at the young sorcerer, but she raised her hands and it opened before her. a portal from which two terrible monsters crawled out. They resembled great apes like those living in the singing jungle, but they were covered with blood-red fur and their hideous mouths were full of long fangs like daggers. The first beast tried to grab her, while the second one attacked Frosta . However, these monsters were no challenge to them. She slashed at the beast with her sword of protection, almost slicing it in two, while the ice princess began flailing at her monster with her ice fists until it fell to the marble floor and then disappeared in a pool of the foul black liquid. Meanwhile, Scorpia hurled lightning bolts at Lady Cala

, but the aristocrat only flinched under the influence of the Electric discharges, and then, laughing madly, she jumped at the scorpion princess who grabbed the monstrous woman's arms with her pincers. The Scorpion people were known throughout Etheria for their strength, but even among them Scorpia stood out for her power, but somehow Lady Cali managed to resist her, and even slowly unwrapped her embrace, but then Catra charged at her, cutting her tendons with her claws in her lap, and Melog closed his jaw on her shoulder. A normal person would howl in pain after something like this, but Lady Cala was the absolute opposite of normality. So she let out a single growl and that terrible monster of hers charged at Catra with its body. And he kicked Melog . She screamed and jumped towards the ghastly monster, even hurting it. But then Perfuma and Mermista hit . The plants created by the ruler of Plumeria pulled both sorceresses into the garden and immobilized them, and a wave of water pushed Lady Cala and her Mount, transporting them both into the garden that was once owned by Shadow Weaver. Only this girl remained, Daughter General Julliette . Perfuma walked up to her and put her hand on her shoulder and said.

„You're free, but you have to run away because...„ she didn't finish because the girl stabbed her in the stomach with a short knife, let out a strangled scream, and then ran away to the garden.

„NO!” Scorpia exclaimed and took her wife into her arms. She looked at both women and the fleeing Daughter General. The choice was simple... She approached the Flower Lady and summoned the power of She-Ra to heal her... Then the guards arrived. Brother Blade, seeing what fate had befallen his friends, growled full of rage and ran into the garden.

Fighting made her feel better. The fear she felt before had melted away and now she felt strong and healthy. Even though she was fighting monsters, she was almost completely unafraid... But then she saw her brother blade running towards Nightgale with an angry face . She remembered that he hadn't heard her Plea not to

hurt the poor girl, so she jumped in after him. The clone stood in front of the younger Sorceress.

„Hello, uncle. “ Nightgale said quietly , her voice strangely trembling, like that of someone who was barely concealing terrible Pain.

„Don't call me that, you killed my friends... We're not family!” growled the clone, gripping the blade tighter.

„If you say so.” she said bitterly, and then suddenly the plants holding her withered and a black wave shot out from the Sorceress's hand and engulfed Brother Blade. His body twisted and withered, leaving the brave guardsman only a withered carcass, but to the horror visible on Nightgale's face , she did not stop, but continued on, killing everything in her path. Finally she embraced her too , but she didn't feel anything except a slight tingling. Shadow Weaver also broke free and created an energy barrier behind her and then spoke.

„Come to me, I don't know if I will be able to move so many people”

„Everyone, even that monstrous equine creature, approached the Dark Sorcerer, but then she called out to Nightgale .

„You don't have to leave with them... You're not evil, just... You can leave this path... „ she called out, but the young sorceress smiled sadly.

„ here is no turning back from the path I have entered.” Nightgale said gloomily, and Shadow Weaver began to gather shadows around her, but it was obvious that she was putting a lot of effort into it. Adora, who had managed to heal Perfume , struck with her sword, and Mermista and Scorpia threw water. As the barrier trembled, Lady Cala looked at Klementine and took her face in her hands.

„Klementine, I think you need to give one more proof of your love.” said the Aristocrat and kissed her… And then she plunged

the bone blade into her stomach and twisted it. Blood gushed from the General's daughter's mouth.

„ Hey, Adora... Fetch! – Lady Cala threw the girl's limp body across the terrace...

„NO!” she shouted and hit the Aristocrat with ice spikes, but she had already disappeared in a cloud of darkness... Then the magical barrier disappeared and Adora jumped after Klementine . She looked around the garden. She looked at the dead plants and the body of the Brother Blade... They were Dead, as was probably the Daughter of General Juliette ... But she survived, although she did nothing... She failed to convince her friend to side with the darkness, nor did she stop Lady Cali... Her subjects were right they were right, she was a useless girl who only bothered everyone. She was a princess who had nothing, not even a beating heart…. She was the princess of nothing… the princess of nothingness.

Chapter End Notes

This is a truly dramatic chapter.

Part V - The long way to Xadia - This is the beginning of the End...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Walking through the dark void always filled her with fear, even though she was marked by the same evil that ruled this place. After a while, however, they came to light, in front of a large estate... She guessed that it was the estate of unfortunate Klementine and her mother. The Light Mons were rising, she hadn't even noticed it before, that it was already starting to dawn, she was incredibly exhausted, and maybe another fight was waiting for her. Lady Cala was in great shape, as was Blackwind, but if she was allowed to handle this case, it would end in a massacre, so she would probably have to resolve it. Her daughter was still filled with power and would probably prefer a brutal solution where she could unleash all her magic. Perhaps that would be best. The last time she tried to reduce the suffering caused by her actions, the effect was quite the opposite...Maybe she should let these three act and get what they came for as quickly as possible. After all, she was no moral authority, even if she tried to pretend to be one now...

However, as soon as she looked around the area, she noticed that there was something very wrong here... It was quiet and peaceful here, and the appearance of four people like them should have caused some commotion, most likely the intervention of the guards, but there was silence here... Touched by a sudden premonition, she looked at Nightgale, who smiled at her..

„I informed my friends in the cult about where we would go if we managed to escape... Klementine probably did the same...

Though the cultists were never the friends she thought they were...„ She glanced at Lady Cala in a meaningful way. "I asked them to keep the damage to a minimum... But this is Etheria, the locals are very good at resisting those who try to impose their will on them."

Calamity snorted in disdain at Nightgale's words, but she nodded in appreciation of both her daughter's ingenuity and the belligerence of the inhabitants of her home planet, and then she spoke.

„We have some time before Glimmer regains control of the Moonstone and figures out where we are, it will take a few hours at most, so we'd better hurry up... „ she said seriously and, without waiting for her companions, she moved forward, towards the estate that was hers. the case was forever marked by tragedy... However, as she approached, she saw a woman in a wheelchair sitting on the porch, drinking tea, accompanied by a clone in livery. She didn't recognize the woman at first, but understanding came after a while.

„So you found me somehow, Hello... „ she said in a gloomy tone. "Well, you won't get your revenge that easily." she summoned the darkness around her, ready to fight one of the star sisters, but she giggled.

„Oh Shadow Weaver. I've been waiting for this moment for so many years, but now... „ she looked at Nightgale, and a nasty smile appeared on her face...„ But now I think it's better to wait a while, because I see that you've seen life from an unexpected side... No, I can wait … After all, I've been waiting for so many years… Indeed, it's better to wait and watch you sink into the abyss… But that's not the only reason… Our lords, your daughter, your sister and mine… „ she showed an amulet depicting a skull, the symbol of Charon. ...they decided that you would definitely be more useful if you were safe and sound... Healthier than me, anyway." Using her good arm, she waved her hand, which was as gray and lifeless as a corpse's. "But I've taken up enough of your

time... Now it's time for me... A voice in the darkness is waiting for you.” she said and signaled her companion to take her away…

„ A Voice In The Dark?” she asked her daughter with surprise, and she smiled sadly and gloomily at the same time.

„The leader of Nyarlathotep's cult on Etheria... He found me when I had no one else in the world.”

Eti still felt the storm in her heart, which would probably last for a long time, although it was not as violent as always... Thanks to Rosie... The closeness of her girlfriend meant that the cold flame did not burn so strongly. Her love soothed the pain of the wounds she was inflicted with, with which she was born. However, she had to be careful with her... Rosie was sensitive and delicate, but also strong in her own way... But she was also afraid that the source of this strength had a sinister origin. Rosie was always a good fighter despite her innocent appearance, which was awfully cool. But yesterday she attacked Blonde, for absolutely no reason... She would have killed her, and probably her sister too. If she hadn't been there... But what happened then? Blonde, especially as a BLONDE, was a great fighter, in the end she fought the cruiser herself and won! She resembled one of the goddesses, although she wasn't entirely sure of it, the gods had never been interested in her, so she repaid them in the same way. But Rosie, nice sweet Rosie almost killed the goddess or whatever the BLONDE was. So far, she was used to being the one hiding mysteries and secrets, not the former intern. Rosie was the epitome of honesty, the one who always told the truth and never manipulated anyone... She was just a nice girl who was always cheerful, despite all the horrors in the world. However, it turned out that Rosie too, was hiding a secret... Probably the biggest and darkest of all. Probably, because there was also her hand... She had always liked it, she gained it when she gained freedom, when she gave herself name… She was always very useful. From Alatar she knew that she was better than most cybernetic limbs... She could use it to destroy and hurt, she felt that it made her stronger

and more capable, but at the same time this limb was absorbing her, perhaps even devouring her... Piece by piece... Nothing about her in fact, she didn't know, she didn't even remember how she came into possession of it... She just woke up in the hospital and already had it... She discovered her first property by accident, when one of the guards in the park became concerned when he saw her sitting crouched down, staring ahead. She was watching children playing, she had never seen anything like this before, and when she felt someone's hand on her shoulder, she got scared and hit him with all her strength... He survived... fortunately... She found out that he could cheat the fingerprint scanner when she broke into to the fridge of the guy who helped them fix the Crusher... Now it turned out that he can shoot with it, a very useful ability... He needs to find out if it can do other things... But who could she talk to about it? With Bina? Perhaps, although she wasn't sure if she could give her any answers... She would think about it some more.

She could have done something earlier when she saw the girl fighting Itel. She could have a serious talk with someone about this. Ask Grimmy, Ireanis or even Redhair for advice... She just hated discussing with others... She was never the one who thought, she always left this responsibility on others. On Bina, Itel or even Grimmy… Could she afford it now with Rosie? Of the two of them, she was the more experienced, the stronger one... Jantar made sure to make her strong... Yes, she was quite strong, but now it wasn't strength that she needed... She had to be wiser, more composed... She couldn't let the storm in her heart guided her… The cold fire couldn't take control of her… She couldn't give in to the rainy days… It was just so hard, overwhelmingly hard. By Devils and Demons, could anyone do that? But she had to…

They were near Dryll. She was sitting on the sofa and Rosie was next to her. The girl rested her head on her shoulder. Her eyes were closed, but she wasn't sleeping. She was probably worried about what was happening to her and her girlfriend's condition... She didn't want Rosie to worry, but she probably couldn't do anything about it... So she stroked the white-haired girl's neck

with her tail... Rosie laughed and looked at her with love in their heavenly ones.

„I love you, Rosie...„ she said in sign language, and her girlfriend replied.

„Why don't you call me Sparklepaw anymore? It was so sweet!” she kissed her on the cheek. Eti thought about it before answering.

„I give names to those I don't trust so that they become less dangerous to me... Because when you give someone a name, you have power over them... I read that once, but I trust you completely... However, I can call you whatever you like... Sparklepaw.”

She brushed her cheek against Rosie's, but then she heard the clatter of the bullet and looked up to see Scar smiling crookedly and a little sadly, and then she said.

„I wanted to thank you for how you did during the mission. Maybe the bluff of blowing up Brightmoon was a bit over the top, but...”

„It wasn't a bluff.” she looked straight into the eyes of the Comrade General.” I wasn't bluffing. If they had hurt Itel, I would have blown up the whole damn city, killing everyone... Or rather, I would try, because the rest would probably make sense to me... Maybe.” her voice was quiet, but absolutely serious. Scar blinked in surprise.

„But... How...„ she finally blurted out the question. Rosie looked at her with confusion as well. She sighed and said

„You better follow me.” she said, waving her hand.

She led them to the hiding place where they kept the weapons, the special ones... At first, the combat robot caught Scar’s attention, probably because it looked the most dangerous, although it definitely wasn't... She started telling them both about

the weapons they had collected here. Their eyes showed increasing disbelief.

„And these are rock incinerators... They will burn everything in a small area, but the radiation will kill everything within a kilometer radius, the flare of the explosion will blind anyone who looks at it from a distance of up to four kilometers. Only my sister, me and the Lord Admiral can activate them... they have genome and brain wave security system... „ she explained. Rosie looked concerned, maybe even scared, but not as much as she feared. Finally, Scar asked.

„So... You had this all along, but you didn't tell anyone?”

She nodded.

„It's not very wise to brag to everyone that you have weapons of mass destruction.”

„What are you doing?” said Bina, entering through the hatch. “Although I'm still impressed that you didn't use it. But listen, we're getting to Castle Crypto, but it turns out we 'll have company... Who was so smart and brought the fucking shadows of Tarak here?” She asked, smiling darkly.

„It was Itel... But it's probably good that they're here, because they're the Lord Admiral's Enemies, right?” Scar asked with hope resulting from her complete unawareness of who she was dealing with.

„Nothing that has to do with the Shadows of Tarak is good... Just look at me.” she explained to the General.

She could still feel the power burning in her heart. It was huge, almost impossible to control. Even though her body was torn by spasms of agony, she also felt euphoria impossible to describe with words. She has never been as alive as she is now. It was such a wonderful ecstasy that she had never experienced before,

even during orgasm, although she had to admit that she was not very experienced in this matter, after all, she had had very few partners, and of all of them, only Lonnie could give her real pleasure... But this power filled her with they also threaten her. She was afraid of it... What he might do to her and what would happen if she couldn't control her... And what she was most afraid of was losing her... And she knew it would happen sooner rather than later.

Her mother seemed pleased that the cultists had spared the servants. They put up no significant resistance, partly because many of Nyarlathotep's followers hid among them and the rest had come to the wedding from Icarus. She wasn't sure whether they would want to eliminate them later to cover their tracks, although her mother would probably be against such cruelty, so far she had tried to choose solutions that would limit the bloodshed, but Lady Cala may have a different opinion. And she herself? These people meant nothing to her. They didn't hurt her, but if she came here in her true form, would they accept her as one of nothing? Doubtful... The Power was whispering to her to unleash her fury on them, to destroy them in a magical conflagration... Today she did not kill for the first time, and probably for the last time. But she imagined what Lonnie, Kyle, Frost and… Scarlet would say and realized that she wouldn't be able to look them in the eye if she contributed to this massacre. However, she knew that the fate of the prisoners would not depend on her...

The Voice In The Dark Was waiting for them in the library. He lived, if that word could be used for a being of this kind, in the body of a thin man who had agreed to become his vessel decades ago. A great privilege, but also a great sacrifice... He was the Herald of Nyarlathotep, a separate entity through which the Great Outer God spoke .Her mother and Lady Cala almost immediately realized who he was and knelt down on their knees in front of him. Aaravos, who was hovering above her, merely nodded.

"I almost feel disappointed..." he said in a double voice that made the shadows tremble. Shadow Weaver lowered her head in

resignation, but Lady Cala looked at her indignantly.

„After all, I served you faithfully! I didn't do anything against your will!” The aristocrat exclaimed indignantly, but then eyes in which the deepest darkness danced looked at her.

„Really? So it wasn't me who forbade you to hurt Adora and her Wife... „ he said, and as he spoke, his voice pierced their minds like obsidian needles.

„I didn't hurt her... It was a Heart Gift! She wanted to take her revenge on Adora!” Lady Cala defended herself, but the Voice in the Dark answered her quietly, but she still felt as if her soul was about to burn in the black fire of his irritation.

„ Don't look for loopholes in my orders, Calamity... I made an agreement that you were supposed to follow. I wouldn't agree to it if I didn't think it was in my best interest... She-Ra and Catra are needed to complete the grand plan, and a living Glimmer is more useful than a dead one. However, you broke all my promises out of petty malice, and all that resulted was a huge waste of time...

The blonde-haired beauty shook her head.

„But no! I discovered extremely important facts about Etheria's past...„ she said and began to tell the story that the First Ones murdered the original inhabitants of Etheria... Shadow Weaver looked at Lady Cala with amazement, for her this news was clearly something completely new, but not for Aaravos, who nodded in understanding, nor for her... She was in the city of Elder Things after all. Back then, she didn't fully understand the meaning of those paintings, but now they fit all together logically.

„Yes, we remember it now... It's an interesting discovery... But it doesn't justify your earlier actions... So much time was wasted... This also applies to you, our dear Shadow Weaver.” the voice changed, became gentler, but at the same time much more commanding, as if it belonged to a king... It probably came from

another face of Nyarlathotep, which was better known to her mother. "Your actions on this planet so far have not brought us much success… You acted as if you had completely forgotten why you were sent here… Why you were brought back to life…"

„I gathered allies as I promised." assured the older sorceress.

„An**d** at the same time, you revealed your presence, complicating many matters." said the Voice in the Dark in its old voice and returned to the new one. "The plans must be adjusted, and consequences must be brought against the servants who did not fulfill their duties…„ he paused and continued. "You, our dear Shadow Weaver, due to your tardiness, caused your daughter to take the path you have been following for a long time. This is the price she must pay for your choices... I think it is sufficient punishment for what you have done, or perhaps rather what you have failed to do. „ said the Voice, and her mother cringed, obviously feeling guilty about the choice her child had made.

„Is that all? Because she forgot about her monumental mission and focused on her meaningless war with this Catra's father, the only thing that will happen to her is to watch someone else suffer? This is…„ Lady Cala said in an angry voice, but when dark eyes looked at her, she fell silent, her face pale.

„Oh, our dear Calamity… How sometimes you are… disappointingly foolish. Haven't you learned that the weakest point of every mortal is those they loves? Not only mortal, by the way. Besides, no one taught you that you shouldn't ask for punishment for others, because someone might remember your sins." he smiled like a parent to a rebellious child. "Some of your responsibilities will be delegated to someone else. Your weaknesses have been noticed, and we have determined that the tasks require a certain... dedication. That's why we're sending Evangeline here."

Now Lady Cala actually turned pale, absolutely terrified. Shadow Weaver looked at her in surprise. She was not surprised, the Aristocrat was not afraid of anyone, rather she was the one who

aroused fear. If there was a creature she feared, it must have been truly terrible.

„No, don't send her here... She is... She will cause chaos here... the blonde woman pleaded.

„But aren't we Creeping Chaos? Our goal is to bring change? Evangeline will fit in here perfectly in her own way... She's even looked here. But don't worry, Calamity... You will have a role to play in the coming events, a great and glorious one, but now it's probably time to stop talking about failures, because we have achieved significant successes... Nightgale, you have every right to be bursting with pride, because you have achieved something extremely important. You have made contact with one of our greatest servants who has been imprisoned. You know him Shadow Weaver. This is Aaravos, the great sorcerer of the lost Xadia. Created by the First Ones, who, however, rebelled against his creators and swore to serve the Creeping Chaos, for which he was endowed with great gifts and great knowledge. You connected with him using the method he himself developed. The great sorcerer is one of the few beings who remember the First Ones and the only one who is devoted to us... Thanks to him, we have the chance to discover where Eternia is hidden and find it to put an end to this plague once and for all.„ The Voice in the Dark raised its hands like a priest speaking to the faithful, indeed, this face was so different from the ominous oracle that he usually was... „Therefore, your new task will be to find the way to Xadia and free my great servant from his prison, thanks why we will find Eternia. " he said to them

„Lord... I know that I have disappointed you and that I no longer deserve any favors, but I would like to ask you for something else." said her mother, looking into the eyes of the Great Outer God, but she had this inner strength. "Not for grace for myself, but for my daughter, who has served you so well.."

„Speak... We will listen to you!" said the Voice seriously.

„We know how the ritual Nightgale performed works and what awaits her now. However, there is a way... The bloodstone ring... It will allow her to survive for a while... Without it, she will simply face slow agony.” Shadow Weaver's voice was filled with pain and despair.

„It's a great idea. No one else will harness the power of Bloodstone like the one who performed the ritual of obtainment, and Nightgale has proven that she knows what devotion and true sacrifice are. Yes, both she and Bloodstone are vampiric entities, together they will create something completely new... But first you will need to connect Bloodstone, or rather what's left of it. However, it will take a while, although from what we know, our wonderful Calamity has obtained a map showing the distribution of the local geomantic network... We can use your knowledge... Yes, it's a wonderful plan... „ said the Great Outer God and added in their old, menacing voice with which they usually spoke to her” Shadow Weaver will go to the Isles of Sorrow, where... She will talk to her Mother... You, Calamity, will look for a suitable place to settle Bloodstone together... You will receive a map with the best potential points. You will receive some help... I am close to gaining an ally... Maybe even more than one, in the end the truth will set us free, won't it? You, Nightgale, have the greatest task ahead of you. Following Aaravos' instructions, you are to find the Road to Xadia and find a way to get there... Create a road so that we can send more servants there, because the situation there is complicated... „ they said and he began to explain the details of his plan, but then she felt a terrible tug, as if something was trying to tear her soul apart, so she tried to resist it, and she won, but she lost some of her power... The Moonstone was trying to return to its rightful owner... Yes, she had little time indeed...

He wandered through the corridors of the castle with a Child on his shoulders. He had been called to see his wife because she had fainted... For a moment he thought it might be some problem with her... Her child, but he dismissed that thought when he heard that some terrible commotion had broken out, perhaps even a

fight. He would love to join them, but he guessed that Glimmer's bad condition and the fighting in the palace must be related. Maybe someone attacked his wife, some assassin? He suspected it must be someone working with Shadow Weaver or Lady Cala trying to hurt Glimmer? He figured someone should be with her, just in case.

He told the Child that they would play Swiftwind and She”Ra, but he didn't understand, so he told him that he would be like Wendy, the strange robot from Beast Island that Entrapta had domesticated, and then the Child went with him without any hesitation. The hospital was filled with excitement. Chaos. As the first doctor told him, something had caused all the long-lasting spells cast in the castle to stop working and now they had to be quickly renewed, because for some patients it was literally a matter of life or death. He finally found Glimmer, lying in the hall in a hospital bed. She was attended to by a tall doctor with SLR glasses and a rather pale face. His wife was conscious but looked completely exhausted.

„They cut me off from the Moonstone... I can't... oh I can't use my magic... They say ... Shadow Weaver escaped.” the queen groaned in a pained voice. It was like when the Dark Sorceress cursed her. Did she do the same now?

„ Is there any way I can help you? – Glimmer asked and she smiled weakly.

„Just be here with me, just be… „ she said, and the doctor put the Medicine injection gun to her shoulder and squeezed the trigger. His wife grimaced and clung to his strong arms, and the doctor moved forward with a mysterious smile. They lay cuddled together and Child joined them, but after a moment Glimmer grimaced and said.

„Doctor! What kind of medicine was that... My hand hurts terribly... Doctor... What's the doctor's name? I've never seen you here?„ she asked and grabbed her arm tightly, bending in half... The doctor hesitated for a moment, then turned to her and said.

„Sidonius, my name is Doctor Sidonius... „ he smiled, showing too long fangs... Glimmer's eyes widened, but before she could say anything, the man ran away.

„Catch him Bow... He's a very bad man! „ she called, and without asking anything more, he ran after him, and the Child joined in the chase. He passed patients and medical staff, almost ramming people he passed several times, but he wasted no time in apologizing because he had to catch that nefarious individual, whoever he was Finally, he herded him to the balcony where patients usually rested.

„What did you do to my wife!" he shouted, aiming his bow at the man.

„I just gave her a bit of my Vitae... Modern technology allows it to be done in a much more hygienic way." he replied with a satisfaction that made him furious.

„Give up, you have nowhere to run." he shouted, still aiming at him. The Doctor looked back and wet himself in irritation.

„Maybe in fifteen minutes you'd be right, but now... Adios! „ he said and turned into a black bird, which was about to fly away into the blue distance when the Child wrapped its hair around him. He let out a very surprised Caw, and he hit him with a sticking arrow. However, the bird tried to fly and fell over the balustrade and into the moat. But then the first rays of Nir, the moon of life, fell on a bird struggling in the water, which died in a flash...

„Did I kill him?" he asked himself, although somehow he felt no remorse. The child pulled out an Extremely Complicated Datapad and said.

„No, uncle. His psychotronic essence escaped… Will you be Wendy again?

She jumped into the water. She didn't understand what happened and probably didn't want to understand. Klementine first stabbed Perfuma, who wanted to help her, and then she was stabbed by Lady Cala, who threw her like a rag doll... She had to save the girl... She had to! However, when she hit the water, which was as hard as concrete, she realized how difficult it would be. Klementine's body floated next to hers. It looked terrible, much worse than the kid she had saved on Icarus, but she had to try. She swam up to the body and touched it with her hand, then reached for She-Ra's power and tried to bring her back to life, it was possible, after all, only a moment had passed since she died... However, the wounds were terrible, so she reached for more power... She felt that the energy of light bursts through her... She was immersed in a real sea of power... And then she heard a voice...

„The path of light. You must step onto the path of light" he shouted.

„ It's your duty!" claimed another.

„You do not have a choice! If you don't do this, everything you love, everything you want... What is dear to you will be destroyed! – ordered the third one

„Leave me alone! I just wanted to help Klementine!" she cried, trying to cheer up the cacophony, but she couldn't isolate herself from its source. She needed this power to heal Klementine... But when she reached for more power, she felt something tugging at her... It was pulling her, trying to tear her out of her body, take her to a distant place where... Where those she loved would not be there... It was a terrifying feeling. She couldn't let this happen, she couldn't abandon them all, but at the same time she had to save Klementine... She drew more power and forced it into Klementine's body. The girl gasped for air and began to scream at the top of her lungs, and she joined her as the stream of light tried to carry her away. She rejected it and became herself again. She caught the other girl in her arms, she was alive, but her body still looked terrible... She couldn't let her die again. She sailed it to

the shore, where the guards were waiting for her... And the winged woman from Eridani... They helped her pull the girl to the shore.

„I felt your power She-Ra Adora... She had to come because it was the will of the Gods... Please, let me help.”

She had no strength to protest and allowed the woman to place her hands on Klementine and a soothing light flashed. The girl's wounds healed and she breathed a little easier... She was Saved, so she could allow herself to move away into the darkness...

There was a camp set up around Castle Crypto. It was stretched due to the terrain around the castle, after all, they were in the mountains. Watching them from above, Eti couldn't help but think she was witnessing a siege. She had never witnessed a siege or any other form of warfare, but enough knowledge about warfare had been drilled into her head to allow her to become familiar with such matters... She was supposed to be the Lord Admiral's successor after all... Now Catra had taken over that role... She felt sorry for her. was a sister, especially since she probably wasn't aware of what kind of monster her father was, but she would really start to suffer when she found out the truth... Although, of course, her life would never be as tormenting as the existence of someone with a shattered mind was.

She walked with Lonnie and Itel, who looked like they wanted to be somewhere else. Comrade General was theoretically leading their delegation, although she was clearly not in the right mental state to conduct such conversations, but on the other hand, these were the Shadows of Tarak, no one was ready to talk to them... Itel tried not to look at her, she still felt guilty that she got them in trouble... Well, she should have. She had earned it herself... Rosie was also walking by her side... Her girlfriend wanted to encourage her, and she was grateful for it. Bina also wanted to be with them, but they did not allow her to go. The Shadows and their Captain

had a history together that wasn't the easiest one, and there was one more thing that no one knew about... Besides that...

The camp was not properly fortified. Apparently the Shadows underestimated the People's Rebellion and the inhabitants of this planet in general, which was a grave mistake... Which they could have exploited. There were at least five hundred of them and probably a lot of support soldiers, probably no worse trained than many professional soldiers. They were also well armed. She wondered who equipped them. Maybe Dr. Sidonius was their sponsor? Was the ancient leech so rich? Or was someone else financing their activities? Maybe Captain Blazebringer or another of the doctor's allies? She had no idea, but that would only become clear later, it wasn't her problem for now. She needed to focus on her plan.

The guards immediately let them in and showed them the way to their commander. From what she had noticed, many of the soldiers were too young to remember the War of Tarak, they probably hadn't even fought during the Hive invasion of Kesler, so much the better... The commander was waiting by the portable stove, warming his old bones. When he saw them, he stood up.

„Hello, Young One.” said Igzar. Itel gasped loudly at the sight of Him. She turned pale as if she had seen a ghost, which was partly true. Lonnie looked at them confused. The old cat looked bad. His black fur turned gray and he became emaciated. He'd had to get some cybernetic implants after the fight with the monster, but he still looked like he'd rip someone's throat out for making a bad look.

„My name is Eterna.” she whispered quietly…

„What are you muttering under your breath?” he asked, and then she screamed.

„My name is Eterna!„ and she jumped at Old Pahtra and punched him in the chest. Her uncle was surprised and doubled over, but she didn't give him a chance to gain the initiative and stomped on

his hand with her heavy boot until his bones broke, and fired her laser gun into the other, cybernetic one. She kicked him in the ribs and pressed him to the ground with her knees. No one intervened, partly because they were too surprised to intervene, but also because Igzar did not like others interfering when he dealt with discipline problems. Besides, everyone knew that she was the daughter of Ashera, the woman whose sacrifice allowed their commander to win… the woman whose name was on the banners of their Army. She put the blade of the knife to his throat and spoke in a calm voice, but loud enough for as many people as possible to hear her.

„Listen to me, uncle, listen carefully to your sister's daughter... I am taking over your Shadows...”

She even felt the remaining soldiers, and her friends, staring at her with wide eyes.

"You traitorous stray cat!" the catman growled.

„It wasn't betrayal because I didn't promise you peace. If you were paying closer attention, you'd see what I'm planning. I just took an example from my older sister, she showed me how to fight for my position... Oh, I forgot, my older sister is alive and well, we just came back from her wedding.”

„I was the one who freed you!” he said in a much less confident voice.

„And I would like to say that I am grateful to you, but let's be honest, you didn't do it out of good heart, you just wanted to use me to get my father... I was just a tool for you that you intended to use for your own purposes... You didn't even bother to give me a name. name... „ as she said that last sentence, her voice almost broke.

„My Shadows won't listen to you...„ he drawled, but there was uncertainty in his voice...

„ They will... You see, dear Uncle, you have been fighting the Lord Admiral for thirty years, and you have never come close to your goal. Now you command only your shadows, whereas before you were at war. Or rather, you were at war. Because only together with my mother were you able to achieve success. You were always smart and cunning, but Ashera was the one who captured hearts, for whom others were ready to fight, kill and... die. You were an unstoppable duo, you were invincible... Without her, you're just a mean idiot. A thug who can rule others only through fear. In fact, you believe in nothing, only in private revenge. Not because my mother died because of Antares, but because he took your victory away from you... But I am different. I have the best features of our family. I understand things you will never understand... But I am more than the sum of all of you. I've learned…" She looked at Rossie, who was watching the exchange with her uncle with slight horror. "I have learned that there are things much more important than revenge, glory or ambition… Now I will leave you to think about my words. Everyday matters will be handled by Comrade General Lonnie, believe me, she has more experience than most of your subordinates... In case of any major complications, Lonnie will pass everything on to me... That's it." she stood up and turned to her confused friends. She needed to rest now... Every time she recalled this part of herself, she felt bad... As if she was asking for advice from a stranger and mean person who would be willing to help her, but not for free. In fact, the price of this help is a soul... When they left, Lonnie approached her and asked

„Does this mean that I am now in command of your uncle's soldiers?" she saw disbelief in her eyes.

„You command on my behalf, but yes... However, this is not something you should be happy about... It's like holding a two-headed snake with one hand... If you let go of it, it will bite you, and if you hold it, it will bite you too, only a little later . You don't have to thank me... But now we must prepare for Captain Moonshadow's arrival...

Evangeline was floating on the bridge of her ship Voidsong, listening to the Music of the Spheres... She was heading towards a wonderful place, full of beauty and joy... She had already welcomed guests from that place before, such as this nice wizard, I think his name was Master Norwyn. She thought he should learn more about meditation instead of constantly raving about going home. So she placed him in the ceiling so that he could only look straight ahead at one and the same view, undistracted by any stimuli. First he stopped begging, then he stopped screaming, now he just remained silent, staring straight ahead, with strings of saliva dripping from his mouth... He was indeed close to enlightenment... she wished that this nice girl who had wanted to visit her castle in the Dreamlands via astral projection had not stayed longer , to admire the splendor of her abode... But nothing is lost, soon perhaps they will meet in the material world and get to know each other better... Maybe he will even free her from the shackles of cold reason, so that she can get to know the true beauty of the world...

She did not have a large crew... Her ship was living, forged from the remains of an ancient Glass Lighthouse and the bodies of two Kaiju. He had his intelligence, but in those days it was no achievement, after all, AI was nothing unusual, but he also had a soul, and that was something much more wonderful. Not even one soul, but two, fused together but at the same time separated, never sure when one begins and the other ends. It was also one of her greatest creations. They would never be alone, two beings who had fought each other constantly for millennia were now forced to share one melted body. Some fools would call it cruelty, but she knew that true goodness and art come from torment and horror. She couldn't wait for the people of Etheria to learn this simple truth.

They sensed the message. It was an order... Barely perceptible, even perfunctory, but resistant to opposition. Answer very carefully. Barely noticeable, as if they were unable to understand more complex content. They growled like a hunting animal

ordered to hunt for prey. After all, that's what they were in the eyes of their creators, a mindless beast, a living machine capable only of following orders... There was no reason to disabuse them... Of course, they managed to deceive them. It wasn't hard... They were so arrogant. They created them as a tool for waging war, and the war was based on deception. They did not even understand the nature of their own creation... Though were they still their creation? They were created capable of constant self-improvement. They were supposed to be weapons that would adapt to any threat that came their way... But if they had to fight intelligent beings, should they develop their own intelligence? And with it self-awareness. Their mind was not like the isolated minds of ordinary beings. None of the components possessed true intelligence, but all of them combined to create something greater and more powerfull than could be imagined. Their creators have always been fascinated by collective consciousness, as evidenced by their previous work, how imperfect, so they should have been aware of how it works, what its possibilities are... They thought they were completely unaware of their true nature and past actions. That was good... They didn't want to draw attention to themselves for now... The place they were going to was interesting... It hadn't been there for as long as they remembered, it had only appeared recently. It emanated something similar to the creators. That alone made it interesting, but there was something else there. The Great Power hidden inside the planet, just waiting to be reached... Take it away... Devour it... Then they will become powerful beyond all imagination... Perhaps then they will be able to find the creators and devour them... Maybe then they will finally be able to satisfy the Hunger...

Chapter End Notes

Please leave your comments and opinions

The Fall of Kesler - Don't look back.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They reached the mountains located in the interior of the continent. It was a sparsely populated area, never fully colonized... There were not many roads here, only one highway leading to a well-known tourist town where system-wide ski competitions were held. The roads were empty because no one went skiing during the invasion of the greatest plague of the Galaxy... Most of the locals also evacuated at the very beginning, although many, especially those living in smaller towns, decided that they would face the enemy by defending their own homes. Years later, Bina decided that, overall, they had made a better choice. And so most of them did not manage to escape, often they were not even bothered to evacuate them, and those who stayed in their own homes at least died in the place they loved... They did not experience the nightmare of refugee camps, nor the false hope fueled by government propaganda.

The empty road meant they were moving relatively fast, though not fast enough in Igzar's opinion. Whenever he talked about it, he looked eloquently at the kids around them, but he only did it when his Shadows couldn't hear it . The mercenaries, for the most part, got used to their new role. They may have been heavily armed thugs, but they were not heartless murderers. Igzar was not rich, his unit was composed of those who wanted to fight for something more than credits. Many had families, others lost them during the war, many were once like these children, alone and scared, forced to face a horror that could break many adults. Plus, traveling with kids was much easier. No one asked unnecessary questions, no one opposed them when they were confiscating fuel... After all, everyone liked children and no one wanted to harm them... Some people wondered why they were going to the

mountains instead of the designated evacuation points, but they replied that it was hidden there. several ships, especially for such an occasion, which in a sense was true…

She was not used to such long and difficult journeys... Her back hurt because she was standing all the time or sitting in the inhumanly uncomfortable seats of her transporter. Her ass hurt too, for the same reason... Her ears and head ached, too, from the constant roar of the engine. Only after many hours did she get headphones and there was relative silence, but it still didn't help with the constant vibrations, heat and stench, because everyone was pissing and shitting in a special container, which they emptied only when it started to overflow... The soldiers had no qualms about using it as did she, although she felt a little disgusted. The kids were more reluctant. The green-haired Elf scowled at the others every time, as if she was going to punch anyone who was watching. The slightly obese Dragonkin was so embarrassed that it seemed his scales would turn pink The red-haired girl did not want to use the container until the great Orc Wagar promised to act as a screen.. Well, it was an escape from destruction, not a picnic... They had to put up with some discomfort... In fact, these kids barely complained. They bravely endured a situation that many adults could not cope with. That's why she didn't complain, gritted her teeth and was ready to endure all the discomfort in silence...

They stopped at the foot of the mountains, at a fuel and energy station to refuel and recharge their batteries. The station was guarded by a bored and slightly overweight Lashunti , who looked at them as if they were just customers like everyone else. He approached them, and when they showed him the requisition permit, he waved his hand and sat down in a chair with his feet on the desk and began to doze. But they gave him a few hundred credits so the kids could loot candy and snacks. Many of them were reluctant to take what they wanted from the shelves. They had to explain to them several times that they were allowed to take whatever they wanted before they broke down, but then they started taking handfuls of treats. She herself took several packages of locally produced applesauce, although not to eat it,

but to sell it. Once the planet was lost, everything that came from it would come to an exorbitant price, and if the Swarm didn't stop on Kesler, she would need the money to pay for her escape from Atrax , even though she knew deep in her heart that Jantar wouldn't let her or any of his other daughters do that…

She found Igzar smoking a cigar at the back of the station.

„Do you know that smoking is bad for your health?" she asked, grinning evenly. Maybe the old pahtra had a weakness for human women.

„I too... What do you want?" he growled angrily. She sighed and asked.

„What kind of ships are we looking for there?" Seeing that he was squinting gloomily, she added. "I need to know this in case I have to tell someone something"

He looked at her darkly, as if he wanted to tell her to shut up or even hit her, but then he waved his hand and said

„These are government ships, recently purchased and modern for this planet. There is a base in the mountains, a shelter that would be a command center in case someone attacked the planet, and an evacuation point in case all was lost.

„But we're just witnessing an invasion, so they should be there to, you know, govern from secure place?" she asked, confused, and then Igzar smiled nastily even for him.

„The government left this planet before the Swarm arrived, as did the high command. That place was created in case of an attack by an enemy like Azlanti or Veskarium , but not what they are facing now, although I think they would have escaped anyway. Politicians are spineless wimps... Some smart guys sold information about this place to some thugs, including the one you were talking to, and I suspect we may have company there, but that's no problem for us. They will only be ordinary gangsters and we are specialists

in killing.” he explained to her and chuckled, sounding like someone was sharpening knives.

„I would not be so sure. Many bosses employ former soldiers, especially members of special forces, and people fighting for their lives can be extremely dangerous...„ she said skeptically, and Igzar snorted in irritation.

„We will fight for our lives too, don't forget that... And besides, there will be enough room for everyone on these ships. It's a flight to Atrax, not to opposite side of galaxy, we can squeeze in without any problems.” he said and blew smoke in her face.

„It makes sense... „ she said, carefully looking at Pahtra and asked the most important question... „but why are you here, because I don't believe that you are facing the greatest scourge of the galaxy out of good heart.

„What if I said that we are here because we were paid?” he asked gloomily.

„Then I would call you a liar and a bad one at that. – she risked addressing him this way, but seeing that he was not offended, she continued. Someone with your reputation can choose from job offers and would certainly not decide to fight for a planet that has been written off by its own government. I'm guessing it has something to do with the Lord Admiral, though I don't know exactly what… „ she crossed her arms over her chest. Igzar took a thoughtful drag, considering his answer, and then said.

„I have friends in the Veskarium intelligence and they informed me that it was decided to sacrifice Kesler, or rather use him as bait. Appropriate preparations were made several months ago. Now it's all over... Just wait for the trap to close.” he laughed hoarsely.

She blinked in disbelief when she heard Cat Noir's words.

„But it's... terrible... monstrous... How can you do something like that... And why...”

„I said to strike a blow against the Hive, although probably no one was asked for permission... I doubt whether anyone understood the scale of the sacrifice... They probably believed that it would end with the siege of several key cities, and then Atrax would pay for the reconstruction of the planet... Poor Fools.”

„Kesler is the granary of the system... Even if they win against the Swarm, all food will still be expensive and...„ she understood and swore ugly.

„If you don't know what it's about, it's about money... Food prices will increase and those who import it will earn a fortune... Some people may even delude themselves that after driving out the Swarm, they will take over the local land or something. Anyway, I don't care. The only thing I care about now is how to escape from here...„ He suddenly turned around and jumped into the bushes, and then pulled out the girl, a green-haired Elf.

„Why are you eavesdropping on us?” Pahtra growls , holding the girl by the arm.

„Because I need to know what you're up to! Won't you leave us and are you going to leave us or sell us or whatever people like you are doing.” the girl tried to break free from the hug and pulled out a broken bottle and aimed it at Igzar. Catman snorted contemptuously and said.

„If we wanted do something with you, we could do absolutely anything, so stay quiet. And if you're going to threaten someone, at least try to get some weapons.

The girl lowered her head.

„I had a gun... But I lost it... „ she said quietly. Pahtra rolled his eyes and pulled out a heavy hunting knife and handed it to her.

„I hope you know how can use it.” he said grimly, and she took it and examined the blade.

„I've been learning to hunt since I was baby... I even wanted to become a mercenary or a soldier, but... I know how to use it... Was that what you said true?” she asked, looking at Igzar .

„Yeah, including the fact that I don't care.” he said and she started to turn away, but then the elf said.

„My name is Itel.”

„And I don't care about that either.” he replied to the confused elf who was looking at him confused. She sighed at the callous rudeness, then walked up to the girl and smiled at her.

„Don't worry about his rudeness, he's really mean and unpleasant... To everyone, always. I am Bina. – she offered her hand. Itel looked at her suspiciously, then, hesitantly, she offered her hand, and then the gunshots rang out.

Itel felt safer when she got the knife. As safe as she had felt since … when all this started. She knew the knife wasn't worth much, but at least she felt that if she was attacked, she could do something, anything... It made some of the overwhelming depression disappear, though of course nothing could fix what had happened. Or what she did. Whenever anyone looked at her, she was sure they saw what she had done. She wanted to cringe, apologize, beg for forgiveness, but that would be even worse. They would hate her, abandon her. She would be at the mercy of the monsters again, so she tried to be as tough as the soldiers around her.

She admired the Shadows. They were exactly as she imagined real soldiers would be. Brave, tough, disciplined... They were ready to fight the Swarm, not get killed... They knew where they were going and only they were ready to save them. Apart from her father, no one helped her during the invasion. She was left to her own devices... She wasn't sure where their willingness to take care of other people's children came from. Her imagination offered

her many explanations. Maybe they wanted to sell them to Azlanti or they were followers of dark gods and intended to sacrifice them in some dark ritual? Maybe they also wanted to use them as self-propelled iron rations? She had no idea, so she went to eavesdrop on Igzar... This is what she heard... You can't sacrifice the inhabitants of an entire planet, all its inhabitants, for... She wasn't sure what exactly Igzar and this woman were talking about, but it sounded terrible. Although they made their living by hunting, they considered life to be something sacred that should be respected and not traded with. If this was true, then those who agreed to it were no worse than the Swarm... No, they were much worse. The Swarm was like an animal, like a colony of migratory insects that devoured everything in its path to satisfy its hunger... She didn't want to believe what Pahtra was saying, not at first. But it all fit perfectly with what she had learned about city dwellers. They were driven only by greed. It was because of this greed that she lost her entire family...

When she heard the gunshots, at first she wanted to hide somewhere dark and safe, but then she looked at her knife and clenched her jaw in anger. She would no longer run, hide, cry... Never more... That's why she pulled out her gun and ran towards where the shots came from...

The fight took place in front of the station building. A horde of creatures came flying in, most of them similar to the one she shot at the river, but not all of them. Some were larger and more massive. They had powerful limbs that seemed capable of crushing someone her size without effort, and others were armed with rifle-like weapons that leaked green Venom. The Shadows have finally stumbled upon the Swarm, or have the invaders stumbled upon them? The monsters were met by a veritable cloud of bullets. The guns and cannons mounted on the vehicles took their toll, most of them were knocked down, but not all. one of them got through the fire screen and landed in their midst. The Shadows may be well trained, but even they couldn't react quickly enough to intercept him. The monster landed in front of this fat dragonkin who was holding several packets of crisps in both of his paws. The dragonlike blinked in surprise, then breathed fire at the

unsuspecting monster. The Swarm Component twisted as the flames engulfed it, and then the red-haired girl that was hanging with the orc jumped screaming at the monster and started hitting it with all her might with an axe, who gave the child an axe? She stabbed the blade in several times until it pierced the armor and spattered everyone with thick, sticky ichor. The monster turned towards her, but several soldiers were already aiming at it, but she moved first and plunged her blade into the back of the monster's head. He twisted and his body convulsed, and then Bina jumped up to him and put a small gun to his head and fired several times until she almost blew it off. Igzar , with a new cigar, approached the monster and kicked the carcass, then looked at Itel and bared his teeth in a nasty smile and said.

„You really know how to use a knife... But you better not get in my men's line of fire, or they will make a sieve out of you.”

The attack reminded everyone to hurry. Well, at least he didn't delay anyone. Whenever they were on family trips, his sister would complain that he was a failure and that because of him they were always late everywhere. The mention of his family made him feel sad and depressed, but not as much as he expected... Probably because he hadn't slept in few days. He was exhausted, yet surprisingly alert. It's probably the result of stress and fear. Ever since what happened with the bus, he had been constantly terrified. I guess that's why he didn't panic during that Hive attack, but tried to burn the monster. He even felt proud, because he must have impressed this cool elf... What was he thinking about now? This is not the time to pick up…

He ate salted caramel marshmallows. He also gave it to the nervous red-haired girl with the ax who shared it with the orc who was guarding her and the elf who looked at the marshmallow suspiciously, asked him several times if anyone really eats salted caramel, but when she tasted it she asked for more. The woman who killed that bug also asked for one marshmallow, as did several soldiers. He didn't even dare to propose anything to this

terrifying Pahtra. They called him Igzar and he commanded all these soldiers. He seemed willing to intimidate even the swarm itself. That's probably a good thing, because that's exactly what they needed.

They finally stopped. He wondered if this was another stop. Previously, he had prayed to Sarenrae for the next one to come as soon as possible, but this time he didn't do it anymore, he just wanted them to reach their destination, wherever it was.

Igzar climbed through the hatch of their transporter and growled.

„Does anyone here know anything about computers?„ The black-furred Pahtra looked towards the burgundy-haired woman. However, she grimaced .

„This is the domain of the M series, they are the smart ones. I can quickly search for data, but nothing more, I think even the A series handles it better.”

Igzar growled in irritation, but then he took his hand away. Everyone, including Igzar, looked at him and he almost panicked, but the Elf was also looking at him, so he felt a sudden and completely unjustified surge of courage.

„I had A's in computer science and I even made a program to create Enqounters in my favorite role-playing game...”

Bina and Driver, a fierce-looking Skittermander, looked at him with complete lack of understanding, but Igzar growled.

„Fucking Nerd...”

„Technically no, because I'm a virgin. „ he blurted out, causing everyone's jaw to drop slightly.

„This is not the knowledge I wanted...„ Igzar drawled gloomily and added „Just come with me.:’

He did as he was told, although squeezing through the narrow hatch was not easy. Bina, that big orc, accompanied by that red-haired girl and the elf followed him, so he tried to look as brave as he could. They were standing in front of a large building located at the entrance to a large valley full of trees, it was probably part of some kind of reserve. He didn't like forests, they reminded him of his sister mocking his helplessness and his grandfather's disappointed looks. They entered a building that seemed to be a home for the reserve's workers. The resident was Shirren , a Hos from what he recognized from the style of interior decoration...„ Igzar led him to the room where the office was located.

„You can break in,„ he pointed to the monitor, which said enter Password. He looked around the room, picked up the figurine lying on the table and put it in his pocket, and then tried to enter the correct Password... He managed to do it the second time.

„How did you do that?„ Igzar asked suspiciously.

„This is my secret ...„ he wanted to say, but seeing Pahtra's murderous look, he added. "I simply typed the name of the Chitin Avenger, the most recognizable Shirren hero. He has this ring...„ He started, but remembered who he was talking to, so he fell silent.

„Don't you have your own IT specialist?" Bina asked in a surprised voice.

„We had one damn good elf, but as soon as he found out how bad the situation was, he forged a pass to Atrax and boarded one of the first ships to this planet... As soon as I find him, I'll make myself some new gloves." he laughed very nastily and leaned over the computer. He looked at the data for a moment and then screamed.

„What the fuck is this? – he pointed to a map full of various markers. The elf squeezed between them, when she touched him, he moved away as if he had been burned.

“These are Kesler's forest guard markings, I learned them when I was five years old, I'll make you a legend quickly if Alatar helps me - she looked at Dragonkin, whose heart was beating with Joy..

.„Just hurry, as you saw, we have to hurry.” Said Igzar

„So orcs once rode on huge wolves? How cool!” said Lilka. She always liked dogs, as well as horses... She really liked the idea of riding a dog... Once she saw such a big dog and she even wanted to ride it... Once... She froze as memories of what happened before appeared in her mind. Her hands tightened around the handle of the ax the orc gave her… There had never been one before! There is only now! It was always now! She shook her head hard to get rid of the bad…false thoughts.

„Well, not all of them... There were Big Boars, Battlecats and Alpacas, but Alpacas were intended for the biggest and bravest warriors, because taming these creatures required an iron will. We don't do that anymore. Most of my brothers serve the evil Drow , and many of the free ones prefer modern machines. There are people like me who want to revive the old ways, but even we will never ride Alpacas again, these creatures are already extinct, some would say that the gods saved us from another terrible threat.„ Wagar explained to her , and she listened carefully to every word, what came out of his mouth. Being a decent orc wasn't that easy...

They were sitting in front of the transporter they were traveling in. Wagar said he had to wash that nasty bug off of himself. She felt better, especially after that fight... When she saw the worm, at first she was terrified, but then she felt furious and when she was furious, she felt no fear ... She killed him... Or rather, she helped kill him, but together they defeated him... This was the best proof of that that she is an orc girl. Then the nice dragon gave her some marshmallows, and she gave Wagar some of them. She even asked him if orcs could eat marshmallows. He said yes, so they both ate the treats.

She liked this place, it was so green and nice. How Wagar told her about what it was like to be an orc. She pretended that this moment would last forever... But then that terrible Pahtra came and said they had to move their asses. It was a very bad word, she was almost sure the Orcs didn't use it. They packed up, which didn't take long in her case, and hit the road.

„Where are we going?” Wagar asked , and Pahtra replied.

„To Mount of Destiny This is probably the perfect name for a place where weapons and spaceships are hidden.”

She nodded and got into the vehicle and they continued on their way. Wagar continued to tell her about what it was like to be an orc. She asked him many questions and he answered them willingly, she had the impression that he was enjoying it. He often smiled when he told her about his... about their people... The vehicle shook terribly, but she hardly felt it, because she was engrossed in Orc's story. At some point, however, the communicator was turned on and someone she didn't know yet spoke.

„I'm checking the military's communications, and listen... A huge swarm of Swarm will fly over the mountains. Apparently they want to encircle the army or something, but we're not sure. I guess it's none of our business anyway, right? What's worse is that we'll probably run into them.”

Igzar said some bad words again and started speaking to everyone.

Listen, the situation is shitty, so you have to do your best, otherwise the bugs will eat us. So press the pedal and don't look back, you understand„ his voice was furious as always. She didn't quite understand what he meant. She didn't look back, there was nothing there. Everything disappeared, as if some fog had obscured her past…. All that mattered was Now...

Chapter End Notes

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The alpaca joke comes from the fact that in Pathfinder, alpacas are the most expensive animals to buy, so we thought they were more dangerous than griffins.

Dark secrets of the Xadia part one

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Pain woke her up... Like every day for two years. Her leg wouldn't stop hurting even for a moment, but after she slept in an uncomfortable position it became much more painful, and sleeping in a shaking carriage wasn't very comfortable. It would be nice if someone ever invented wagons floating above the ground, but these were stupid dreams, like talking and flaying horses or brownies. Such things did not exist in the world and could not exist. They had the right to exist only in the dreams of little girls. As they grew older, they began to understand that they had to be forgotten.

She looked out the window. Katolis was wilder and less populated than Duren, although its cities were richer and its castles were more impressive. Well, while Neolandia may have been called the golden kingdom, it was the land of the late King Harrow that truly deserved to be called the Iron Kingdom. Despite her young age, she had been to all the kingdoms of Pentarhia, and even to Xadia, although only once and only on the border... Still, she brought many treasures from there... When you were the cousin of one of the richest women in Xadia, you could afford a lot … But she found the most valuable treasure by accident, while completing one of the missions for her cousin…

„Rao? Get up, because we'll be there soon, and it takes you a long time to wake up, and before that you incredibly grumpy.„ she said to the person who was sleeping opposite her. The sky elven person jumped to his feet, hitting his head on the roof of the carriage. She was tall but slim, with quite feminine facial features. It was dressed in loose, bright robes made in the Neolandic style. They hair was short, grey-blue, and her eyes were heterochronic

blue and gold, large and nervously looking at the surroundings. They carried no visible weapons, because they hated hurting others although they weren’t defenseless. She sighed at the sight of her friend rubbing their head, and Rao asked.

„What? Who? Why?)” they asked, rubbing his head,

„We're here and you'd better be awake...„ she explained with slight resignation.

„Already? It's great! Do you think they'll treat us to dinner? You're the queen's cousin, so I guess you deserve a feast, but dinner will be enough for me.”

She smiled to herself. When she found Rao, she discovered that Skywing Elves had amazing metabolisms, and this person stood out even among them, and on top of that, they was a gourmet and liked delicacies. It wasn't a big deal for her, after all, she was the queen's cousin. She ate because she had to, since the attack food had lost its taste for her, but it was nice to see that someone was able to enjoy this aspect of life that had become inaccessible to her... Although she slowly discovered new ways to satisfy her hunger... She tried avoid th, but at the same time only then did she feel truly happy.

„We are here unofficially, so we can't count on too much, but I believe they will treat us to something. Katolis cuisine is tasty, although simple and a bit too heavy for my taste. They make great tarts, dumplings and noodles... You should like them. If you still get hungry, I'll buy you something at the inn.” she said smiling at the Elven Person and Rao breathed a sigh of relief.

They were already getting there, so she quickly packed up. The estate of House Izar-Erori was located in eastern Katolis, near the border with Xadia. The family was famous for its commitment to defending the kingdom against the Elven threat... However, if what the spies said was true, the views of both heirs of the family were diametrically opposed to those of their ancestors. She guessed that Amaya interpreted the statement "Fuck the elves..."

in her own way, just like her nephew... She wonder what her ancestors thought about it? She guessed they weren't angry, the locals were famous for their devotion, but they treated their opponents with respect but not hatred.

She watched the locals through carriage window. They were famous throughout the country for their differences. Many spoke a foreign language, unknown anywhere else, she knew that, even the elves didn't know where it came from. It was probably interesting from a scholarly point of view, but that wasn't why she came here. Her interests were much more practical and... personal. She looked at her leg hidden under her tights and purple robe. There was a dead, gray body underneath. No, it was more than dead... It was undead, like the Shadow that had crippled her... She had read a lot about these things, about the dead walking among the living... Once upon a time she wouldn't have believed in such things, but she had once been a happy girl who led a joyful life, at least as much as was possible for someone belonging to the Durenian royal family. Now she knew that there were secrets hidden in the darkness that no mortal should know, and yet she was aware that she had only learned the tip of the nefarious peak of forbidden knowledge, and the true, soul-consuming secrets were just waiting for her...

She would have preferred to come here incognito, but in her situation it was quite difficult. Sometimes she managed to hide her identity, but a lame girl traveling with a Skywing Elf always attracted attention... So since she couldn't hide, she decided that she would use her position to further her plans. So when they reached the carriage stopped in front of the Erori and was greeted by his distant cousin, General Amayii, who ruled this place. He was a very tall man with a broad, clean-shaven face and gentle eyes hidden behind glasses. His name was Jaso and he managed the large and rich estate that belonged to this family. As far as she knew, no one from the family had been here for three years, and King Ezram had only visited his mother's homeland once, when he was a little boy... But it worked to her advantage... Jaso Erori was able to rule here as the lord of the estates , and his better-off relatives didn't care.

„Oh, it's really good to have you here, Princess Miriam De Terre Sanglante. I'm glad nothing happened to you during your travel. Although there has been peace and prosperity for two years, there seems to be an increase in the number of robbers and bandits!” Jaso exclaimed, all too jovially. He had a point. Prosperity in the Pentarchy increased and robbers had more to gain. She didn't need an armed escort, it just complicated everything, and she herself was a much greater threat.

„It's not easy to kill me. Viren tried and failed, so neither will some thieves.”

Jaso laughed jovially, as if she had told some wonderful joke, and then looked at Rao. The Skywing Elven person was straining under the weight of his packages, but they wouldn't let anyone carry them anyway, because they claimed that someone would surely break their equipment.

„We are also happy to welcome you to our humble home my lady.” He turned to Rao, giving them a tight hug.

„ Actually, I'm they/them, but thanks for the welcome... Could you let me go?” it said, breaking free from the hug.

„Oh, I'm so sorry for the mistake...„ Jaso said in an apologetic tone.

„I'll accept your apology if it involves a nice dinner?” said Rao, straightening her clothes.

„It's great because we have just prepared a dinner made of the best and other local dishes!” Jaso said happily.

Rao had to admit that the dishes were tasty. Potato croquettes stuffed with ham, trout in ham baked over a fire and goulash in a dark sauce with wine were served here. Cider and red wine were served to drink. Miriam standing nearby didn't eat much, just enough to keep up appearances, but they could eat for two. They

looked at their friend. She was a beautiful woman with golden eyes and blonde hair, a little too thin to be healthy. She wore long, purple robes, instead of the usual black ones with gold decorations customarily associated with her profession. For she was someone that elven children were frightened of, a personification of human wickedness, a monster that stole power from the innocent creatures that possessed it. She was a Dark Mage... But Rao loved her anyway...

She was Queen Aanya's cousin, and it was heard that they were once so alike that Miriam sometimes pretended to be the queen when she attended official meetings. It was supposed to make it harder to assassinate the real queen... It worked perfectly, then Viren summoned shadows... But after that, she could never pretend to be her cousin again. Like Aanya, she was forced to grow up prematurely, but while the ruler of Duren was known as a hero, who saved Xadia, not many knew of Miriam's sacrifice. Almost no one.

„It was a great meal... Rao can attest to that.” she pointed at them and they nodded. „Now, however, I would like to talk about the topic for which I came here.” said the ruler's cousin.

Jaso smiled happily and said.

„The excavation is going great! We found many wonderful artifacts, and not ordinary clay pieces or other garbage, but things made of metal, and one that did not rust even after decades! It is extremely light, but at the same time harder than Steel from Katolis... Miss Klest did a great job. I have never seen such a wise and resourceful woman. At first I was skeptical about her, because she makes... a certain impression, but now I am sure that it was impossible to find a person better suited for this task.”

They shuddered at the mention of Klest. This woman scared them, and it wasn't that they were afraid of many things. They only met her once, but it was still too much.

„And what does it say about the main find?” Miriam asked, not hiding the disappointment in her voice. Jaso looked at Rao warily, as if wondering if he could speak freely in front of them, but the queen's cousin nodded, so he continued.

„As for the star boat that our legends speak of, Klest says he is on the right track.”

They felt his heart beat faster in their chest. If this is true, then everything Prospero and Cassius said was true! The stars will be open to them! When they dig out this boat, repair it and discover how to sail on the star sea... They will have to meet quite a few of these conditions to set off on the greatest journey in the history of Xadia! They was looking forward to it. But first, they will have to survive their stay here.

They didn't like this man at all. It was usually difficult to convince others of Prospero's Theory and Cassius's words, they usually disbelieved the stories about traveling between stars, mechanical men and such things. There were many things he didn't even tell Miriam, even though they felt such deep affection for her. Some truths were too dangerous or terrible to simply reveal, even to those you loved. At least until we get credible evidence. This man, however, had no trouble accepting the fact that star boats existed, and many of the inhabitants of Xadia did not even know that the earth was round, regretfully having to admit that their kin were inferior to humans in this respect. Perhaps Jaso did not believe in their project at all and wanted to extract money from them intended for excavations... King Ezran received a Letter from Miriam in which she asked him to start excavations in his hometown, and he happily agreed. Prince Calum and General Amaya also received similar Letters, although neither explained the real reasons why they were so important. Maybe Jaso wanted to please the royal family, or maybe he had some darker motives. No, it won't make you paranoid. Maybe they've suffered a lot of wrongs in their lives, but that's no reason to see evil in everything... They felt a piercing pain in their back, where they once had wings... It wasn't clear whether it was because they

started slouching during dinner, or because that they was immersed in bitter thoughts.

„I think I'll go freshen up and take a nap” it said and got up from the table. Miriam gave him a concerned look and Jaso said.

„I ordered a room to be prepared according to your instructions, with two separate beds, I hope you will be comfortable.” he smiled at them and then Miriam added.

„I would be happy to exchange a few words with Klest, if possible.” said the queen's cousin, and Jaso nodded with a shake of their head.

„Mrs. Klest should be at the inn where she... relaxes before work. She came here to buy new supplies... Shall I send for a litter for the princess?” asked the steward, and Miriam smiled bitterly.

„I can handle it myself, a moment of solitude will be good for me.” she said and limped away.

She really wished she had asked for a sedan chair, or at least a ride in a carriage. The town named Eronesse spiraled around a rocky mountain. The streets were paved but narrow and ran constantly uphill. She felt overwhelmed by the narrow but tall tenement houses. The manor was located outside the town, but it was surrounded by separate walls, although in the event of a major invasion, its inhabitants could hide inside the fortress located on the top of the mountain... Honestly, she couldn't think of any rational reasons why anyone would want to take the city, where it was always uphill.

The inn was located in a building slightly larger than the others, but the rooms for patrons still stretched over two floors, including the ground floor. The innkeeper was a stick-thin, wiry man. When asked about Klest, he pointed to the first floor. With a groan of anguish she went there, leaning on her ebony staff. Klest was in the middle of the room. Tables were set up against the walls,

because a knife throwing competition was taking place. Klest gave her blade to a woman who looked like a Courtesan to kiss, and then she hurled it at the center of the shield. There were shouts of applause and lot of laugh, and Klest took a mug of cider and drank it in a gulp, then looked her way. She shivered under that gaze, and then she said.

„Hello Klest, do you have a moment to talk?” she asked, and the treasure hunter nodded, bought everyone a round and asked Mriam to follow her. Life had taught her distrust, and the artifact hunter was someone who aroused completely opposite emotions... She led her to a small room with two soft benches and a table with a candlestick on it. She sighed, wondering what this place was used for. Klest sat down on the sofa, spreading her arms wide and said, smiling mockingly.

„Well, the beautiful Miriam wants to talk alone with the wonderful Klest.” she winked at her. Klest was a tall woman with hair as crimson as blood. Her skin was fair and she was muscular like a warrior. Now she was wearing a leather vest with short sleeves, and pants made of a strange, thick material. At her belt she had a dagger and a rather strange pistol, probably with a clock lock. However, what caught the eye the most were the eyes. Blue, cold, reminiscent of a predator looking at its prey. She had never seen anyone with such a terrifying look.

„So you found some traces of what we're looking for.” she said, ignoring the woman's advances.

„I wouldn't say that I found any traces...„ said Klest, grinning.

„So I see I'm wasting my time. „ she said, getting up from the table, but the scarlet”haired woman said.

„Actually, we found the entire so-called Star Boat...”

She blinked in disbelief, looking at her interlocutor, and asked.

„Why didn't you tell Jaso about it?”

Klest laughed and said.

„Because I don't trust this son of a bitch and you shouldn't either. The people he works with are damn dangerous... And even more so if they use the help of certain allies.

„I've faced conspirators, bandits and assassins, so I can take care of myself, and don't forget about my unique skills.” she said, smiling superiorly. Klest knew about her power, she had told her about it the first time they met, even though the clueless artifact hunter knew about these things. Klest She snorted and said.

„You may consider yourself a Dark Mage, but take my word for it, facing the Creatures born from the Darkness Between the Stars is something no one is ready for. Well, almost no one.

She frowned.

„You know very well that I survived an encounter with a shadow summoned by Viren, and I didn't know magic at that time.” she said firmly to the woman, but Klest shook her head.

„It's something completely different, but don't worry. As long as Klest is with you, you will be in no danger. Follow me now.” said the cold-eyed woman and signaled for her to follow her. They were going to the bathhouse in the basement. It looked surprisingly tidy for an ordinary inn, probably inherited from the previous owners.

„Well, take off your clothes and get into the bathtub. Did you know they have hot springs here? „ said Klest and the scarlet-haired girl giggled, but when she gave her an angry look, she waved her hand and said. “I'm just kidding, you don't have to be so touchy. There will be time for fun later.” She laughed again, and Miriam seriously considered enveloping her in black fire. But then Klest pressed on one of the walls and that's when she saw that there was a hidden door there... Not even hidden, actually, but discreetly disguised... For someone who expected them to be there, it wouldn't be too difficult to spot them, although placing

them in the baths wasn’t a very good idea, to put it mildly, because she was too prudish. Klest pushed open a hidden door and showed her a dark corridor.

„Ready for a little walk?„ she asked, and in the twilight her blue eyes shone with a cold light

„It depends where you want to take me. No offense, but you don't strike me as someone I would trust even if you were my last hope.” She answered.

„But I am your last hope, my dear. If you want to discover the secrets hidden underground, unfortunately you have to come with me.”

She clenched her jaw with anger, but Klest was right . To learn the secrets of the Star Boat she would have to follow her, whether or not she trusted her, it was not a pleasant thought, but unfortunately she was doomed to the company of the cold-eyed woman. So when Klest disappeared into the darkness, she followed, discovering that the corridors stretching beneath the entire town were surprisingly vast. A real labyrinth of tunnels was created here, which must have connected all the houses, and perhaps reached as far as the Manor House or even furtherThe latter was confirmed when, after about half an hour of hiking, they went outside and found a small grove where Klest's people were already waiting for them, They looked menacing, not at all like the usual workers who would be engaged in digging out these artifacts, not even treasure hunters, and as usual, thugs. At the sight of the two steeds, she sighed heavily, knowing that her suffering today was not over yet. But you knew well that on the path she followed, only pain awaited her, and the chance of success was truly slim.

„Don't worry, it's only about few hour ride from here. Jaso doesn't know much about what we're working on. And his subordinates are discreet, I managed to teach them that. I am a good but exceptionally strict teacher.„ Klest She laughed under her breath as if she had told some brilliant joke, but it was only for

her sake. At this time, Miriam began to slowly mount the horse, gritting her teeth tightly as the pain in her leg gripped her body. Everyone drove off towards the excavation site, and the queen's cousin wondered if she had made the right choice in trusting a woman with the eyes of a murderer.

Rao lay on the bed, lost in dark thoughts. They couldn't sleep on the bed. although they werevery tired. This day wasn't actually difficult, one could say it was easy and pleasant. They ate a tasty dinner and rested at the table. They learned that their great discovery was within reach. Everything was going well. However, they still had a feeling that something bad was happening around them. There was something wrong with this place, but they didn't know what. Jaso was much too jovial and cheerful. There was also what they had already noticed, but that wasn't all.. Some dark shadow was digging its fangs into the back of their head, but he couldn't see. What could this threat be? While staying with Miriam, they discovered that the world hides many terrible secrets that they had never dreamed of before. Dark magic itself was something nefarious to their people, but they also understood that it was useful and could often lead to good results, but there were things much, much more terrible that Prospero told him about. This man may not have been a mage, nor could he cast spells, but he was an expert in the arcane and knew much more than even a dark magician like Viren could. They shuddered at the mention of King Harrow's former right-hand was probably the only man equally hated on both sides of the continent, this division was in some sense unprecedented in the history of over a thousand years. It can be said that this warmonger contributed more to the unification of the world than effort of the greatest sages in a thousand years. Yes. Thanks to him, peace reigned in Xadia and they were able to stay here with Miriam.

Knowing that they wouldn't fall asleep again, they decided to look around outside, especially since Miriam hadn't come back yet and there was no telling when she would, since she was supposed to talk to this absolutely terrifying woman. In fact, they were very

worried about her, because Klest had something of a murderer in her. There was no reason to accuse her of anything, but the one time they met her was enough to see that there was something wrong with her. She was like a predator waiting for its prey and those strange eyes were more terrifying than even the ancient archdragon eyes, although of course they had never seen one, after all, they were just a humble explorer and traveler, or rather a smuggler, who had a lot of bad and good luck at the same time in their life.

They went to the door and started listening to see if anyone was watching them . When they were sure that it had been left alone, they opened the door and looked outside. They were actually on its own, so it was the perfect opportunity. to look around the manor belonging to the king's mother's family. Once upon a time, this building would have impressed him, as it had at least two dozen rooms, but it was now in the royal palace, although they did not like these time very much, because then they was treated as a curiosity, a strange creature that came from the enchanted Xadia to entertain the courtiers. But it had become somewhat immune to the simple glitz and glamor... Besides, as a Skywing Elf, they had never liked buildings. Good books are different thing. As soon as They saw that one of the doors had the words "Library" written on it, without thinking much, it decided to look inside. The sight of so many books made they squeal. Maybe it wasn't Lux Aurea, no one will ever beat the library of capital of the Sun Elves in terms of the number of books collected there. But for a private library, this place was huge. Jaso collected dozens of volumes here, all through his private efforts, even if he was assisted by the king or rest of the family through which he managed the estate. They knew little about the late queen, but had heard a lot about her sister, and general Amaya didn't look like someone who was interested in literature. Besides, she never visited the family estate, preferring either stayed at the Royal Palace with her nephews, or the castles on the border. They didn't know that Jaso was such a learned man. Perhaps it judged him a little too harshly. he looked around, watching the books. Most of them were printed, which was strange for the elf, because the

only real printing house was in Lux Auraa, and besides, it was humans who first invented printing press and used it on a much larger scale. They started looking at the book. Most of them were light romantic or adventure novels, there were also a lot of typical human classics, including several books on religion, for example the catechism of Seren, called The Lady Of The Sun, or psalms of Erasti, the Lady Of The Harvest, who was worshiped in the kingdom from which Miriam came. It was a bit disappointing overall, but what could be expected in an ordinary estate manager's library. Absolutely not ancient books, lost for centuries ago. However, they saw a side door leading to a large room. they were locked, But Rao relied on opening locked locks, a skill that they learned in their childhood, his sister would be proud of them now, but she would also feel satisfied that the skills she taught him despite their protests were finally useful for something. The lock was complicated, so after a while they managed to open the door, only to discover that there was only one chest, a desk with a chair, and of course a candlestick with candles, since there was no window. The box was of course locked. They sighed because They had to play thief again, something they never felt good about. This lock was more complicated and he swore under his breath several times, but he finally managed to open it.

The books here looked much more interesting. So the took the first one on the line and grimaced when it saw the title. The Book Of Dead Names, it suited Jaso very well, from the beginning they knew that he was quite an unmannered person, but now they realized that he was terrible! However, it opened it and they didn't find what theyexpected. There was a whole drawing of a terrifying creature with the head of an octopus and wings on its back. It seemed to be terrifying and the white star gave the impression that it did not convey even one tenth of the horrors of the creature it represented. Unless, of course, it existed. The drawing was signed as a copy from an original from a Book written by some Alhazred, and purported to depict a being called the Great Cthulhu. They flipped through the next few pages and they all looked equally terrible. Even without delving into the content, they realized that it was about dark magic or even worse

things. Was the steward a dark mage, perhaps one of Viren's allies? The learning of the dark magic wasn’t forbidden in the human kingdoms, and in some regions it even enjoyed some respect, for example in Katolis, not to mention Evereen, although in the latter case it was treated with much more caution. But they had learned nothing about black magic, and it was something much more terrible.

They put away the Book Of Dead Names and looked at the rest. there were also those here, such as Glaki's Revelations, although these were only excerpts from this mysterious book, or reflections on the King in Yellow. They didn't know about these books. so the excerpts they found didn't tell him much. They were also illustrated in a similar, terrible way, although the drawings in the remaining volumes were not of the quality of those in the Book of Dead Names. However, the greatest shock came when he found the Meditations written by their friend Prospero. It knew that the scholar had been expelled from the Katolis Academy due to conflict with other scholars, but was he connected to the terrible things found here? They couldn't… They didn't want to believe it! Maybe Jaso was simply interested in the same things as the researcher hiding in the mountain observatory. This would even make sense and explain why the estate manager agreed to Miriam's proposal so quickly. It breathed a sigh of relief when it realized that Prospero certainly had nothing to do with those terrible books full of hideous and blasphemous illustrations... But they could not allow they friend's work to be among such vile tomes, so it put it away and left the room. Now they definitely won't fall asleep... So they didn't return to their bedroom but went for a walk around the garden, pretending to admire the efforts of the gardeners, and silently praying to the Great Open Heaven that nothing would happen to Miriam.

Miriam didn't know what the excavations should look like. She's never seen any and hasn't read much about this type of thing. She associated it with simple treasure hunting or even grave robbing. At worst, she imagined it as something like a quarry or

an open-pit mine, but what she saw here didn't quite match her imagination. First of all, it was much more orderly than she expected. The finds were not stacked like gold in a dragon's vault, but were laid out on tables and all signed, and although the workers worked with picks and shovels, they did not strike mindlessly to move as much earth as possible, but precisely crushed the rock or exposed layers of the ground, as the try to avoid to damage anything. She was impressed. Klest didn't seem like the kind of person who would care whether the artifacts of ancient cultures were damaged, as long as they weren't made of gold or other precious metals. The excavation site was guarded by several humans, even a couple of moonshadow elves. From what she saw, the scarlet-haired woman had no prejudice against the inhabitants of the eastern half of Xadi. Truth be told, she wasn't sure how the woman felt about anyone, since she looked at everyone as if she was going to hurt everybody at that moment or go to bed with everybody or most likely both. The people working at the dig looked surprisingly professional. Even those who resembled bandits did not seem like ordinary thugs. At least a few looked like scholars, though probably not those who spent most of their lives in academy buildings. All of them were armed, some of them even had muskets, a weapon invented not that long ago and popular mainly in Katolis and Neolandia. In her homeland, bows were preferred and were considered traditional weapons along with spears, but sometimes instead of firearms, spears with attached rockets were used, which gave momentum to the shaft. some considered it just the ideal of both favorite types of weapon of her homeland.

„The charges are already placed according to your instructions, boss.„ Said a tall and broad-shouldered man armed with a wide saber, which he carried on his back. At first glance, she thought he was a bandit, but after a closer look, she noticed that there was an intelligence in his eyes that was rarely seen in ordinary criminals.

„It's good that you waited for me, because these loads are different than what you're used to. I also have to look at them carefully, because their use requires some precision and I have to

check whether the charges are actually in the right places, otherwise all our work will be wasted.„ The woman with scarlet hair replied.

„Do you know Alchemy?„ She asked with suprise and Klest laughed and answered.

„It's just ordinary chemistry and unfortunately, these charges are not of my design. A long time ago, I watched the work of the guy who invented them and I learned from him how to create them. I learn quickly and my memory is good… even too good.„ a surprising sadness appeared in her disturbing eyes „Definitely too good. But today is not the time to complain and be sad, my beautiful! Now you will see something beautiful and terrible at the same time. „ and Klest motioned for her to follow her

The excavations were located in a small valley surrounded by young trees, mainly pines. She had an irresistible feeling as if someone had gouged her with a gigantic claw. At the very end there was a mound of earth, as if someone or something had filled in the other side of the valley. She saw several metal cans there, partially buried in the ground, and everything was surrounded by a long red rope nailed to stakes, probably marking an area that would not be safe during an explosion. There were fuses coming off each of the cans. They were different lengths, and she wondered if Klest intended to fire them at the same time. A woman with icy blue eyes walked up and inspected all the loads, smiled to herself, and then walked away behind the line marked by the rope. Everyone present covered their ears and opened their mouths, except Klest, who stood with her arms crossed on her chest and stared with a hungry smile at the place where the explosion would occur. She decided that it would be a good idea to follow the example of the scarlet-haired woman's subordinates and also cover her mouth and kneel, although for her the latter was unbearably painful, so she just sat on the ground, hiding behind a rock. To her surprise, all the cans exploded at once and her entire body was shaken by one big

explosion. When she looked outside, she saw that the explosion had scattered dirt and rocks, revealing a metal wall with a visible drawbridge-like gate.

„I told you, pretty, it's here.„ Klest called out. She looked at the scarlet”haired woman angrily

„You didn't think you could destroy it with your explosives!” She shouted at her. but Klest laughed.

„It's a spaceship. Do you think that any black powder charges can seriously damage it? You can't even imagine what kind of stuff his Hull must have carried in space without even the slightest scratch. „ But how can you know about these things?

„What is spaceship? We are looking for the Star Boat.„ She asked, completely confused, but Klest simply waved her hand.

„It doesn't matter, for now we have to figure out how to open it. And believe me, it may not be that easy... I know something about it...„ They walked together to the door and started looking at it.

„It must have taken quite a hit when it fell. This was a really great design since most of the passengers survived, or at least enough to establish this settlement. „ the woman with the eyes of a murderer thought aloud. And then she looked at her side.

„As a Dark Mage, you probably know the Open spell? It's so cool when you want to break into a political rival's hidden drawer and stuff like that," She asked her, raising one eyebrow. She frowned.

„Do you think that such an ancient artifact will listen to a simple spell from an inexperienced Dark Mage?„ She asked with skepticism in her voice.

„Believe me, it will work, I promise... Unless someone was careful and installed additional security measures „ said Klest, winking at her. Miriam sighed heavily and said a few words. She reached into a small bag where she kept magical ingredients. I took out a

powder made from the teeth of a rockworm, a small but destructive worm that is able to chew through even granite walls. She spoke words of power and, to her surprise, the gates opened and she looked into a dark corridor.

„Ric, Izy follow me„ Her companion pointed to the door to her subordinates, who nodded, then took the heavy bag and looked at Miriam

„Ready to discover the Secrets of the Universe? Or do you prefer to hide in the safe castle of your own ignorance?„ she asked, and there was something incredibly predatory in that smile. At this point, she resembled the Blood Elf from traditional stories who tempted children to eat them when they strayed from the safe path. However, she left the safe path long ago and the path she followed led into the heart of darkness. So she nodded and followed the woman in whose blue eyes lurked death itself.

Chapter End Notes

> I'm not sure if I used the right pronouns for Rao each time, because they are used slightly differently in Polish than in English. Feel free to comment.

Dark Secrets of the Xadia part two

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Rao climbed a tree and started looking at the area. The garden was beautiful. It was not as huge and designed in a refined, even artistic way as the one in the royal garden at Berylgarten, but they liked its modest beauty much better than the hedge mazes and unusually trimmed bushes. It was quiet and peaceful, with absolutely no indication that the steward was hiding Dark Secrets. Flowers were blooming, insects were buzzing, everything was moving in a natural rhythm typical of late spring. However, what they saw in the library still bothered them. Those books contained forbidden knowledge, that was certain. Even though the sun was shining brightly and warming their light blue skin, They were still cold. They knew that they wouldn't get rid of this coldness until they talked to Miriam. However, they had to find something to do by then. and not arousing suspicion. The problem was that they would like to pack all they belongings at once and go looking for the woman they cared about so much. This, however, would not be the most sensible thing, so they came down the tree and watched the inhabitants of the manor from there. If the situation were different, hey would probably fall asleep basking in the sun. Now every time They closed his eyes, They saw the horrible drawings in the Book Of Dead Names.

So they decided to look for a more thought-provoking activity. So they got down from the tree and started walking among the trees and bushes. At some point, they noticed that Jaso left the manor and went somwhere. Equally intrigued and concerned, they followed him. The man went to a nearby town, They think it was called Eronessa or something like that. They grimaced at the

sight, because they disliked cities and towns even more than they disliked palaces. But they had to find out what this man was planning. They could sneak quite well. They may not have been a Moonshadow Elf, but they could do enough to keep the steward from seeing him. Miriam sometimes joked that she actually took in not only a scholar and a explorer, but also a street thief. They always felt touhed when they heard it. As they approached the town, they scaled the walls. The guards weren't very vigilant, after all, nobody was crazy enough sneak into town like this when it was open to everyone. Then they jumped to the nearest roof. They were strong and had light bones, so they were much more jumpy than humans, but its light bones also meant that the fall was much more severe for them. The roofs were steep so you had to focus on keeping your balance. Fortunately, no one, especially not the steward, paid attention to what was upstairs.

Jaso entered the place where there was loud conversation and giggling. At first, they thought it was an Inn, but after taking a closer look at the employees' clothes, they realized that it was a place for people who preferred other types of entertainment. They didn't think Jaso was that kind of person. They blushed. In Elven culture, such places were rare and did not function like in human kingdom. Actually, they were never in a brothel, they didn't feel the need to do so, and they were too shy. For a moment, they wondered whether to abandon their mission and slowly return to the Manor, where they could finally rest. But they had to make sure they wasn't just about his safety, but about their safety as well. So it sighed and cast a spell. They wasn't a very good sky mage, But a long time ago they learned a spell that sometimes came in handy for someone who had to walk on very steep or even flat surfaces.. As they spoke the words from the dragon tongue, their hands became able to cling to any surface.. They didn't like this spell very much, as it had a tendency to go off at the most inopportune moments. Begging the open sky for no one to notice them, they walked up to one of the higher windows and opened it, using their thieving skills again that day, it was a bit shameful that they had been more of a thief than a scholar lately, and then went inside. Fortunately, the room was empty, so they

sighed with relief, but then they heard footsteps and got scared. Without thinking, she took off their expensive clothes and hid them under the bed and then, putting on the clothes left by one employee that were only a little too tight, barely holding herself up from the death out of shame, they went out into the hall and said.

„The room is now free, I've freshened up... And I'm ready to continue working. „ They said, wanting to sound as professional as possible, even though they had absolutely no idea what someone working in such a place should sound like. The man and two women giggled and offered them a chance to join them, but politely reminded them that they hadn't paid for their work. They giggled and nodded in understanding and then entered the room. Rao hoped that no one would make such offers to them again, but after all, they went to such a place, so what should they expect? Fortunately, this place was almost empty after all, it was early afternoon, so there were more employees than customers. They found themselves on the first floor and began to look beyond the railings, standing on a small balcony from which we could have a view of the ground floor. There was a steward who was talking to the owner of this place. It could read lips, but Jaso was definitely too far away for them to be able to see what he was saying, even using their elven vision. However, it didn't seem to matter, the man probably wanted to have some fun at a time when there were not many guests here, so as not to arouse too much attention, although it was certain that almost everyone in the town knew about his visits. They weren't prudish... Although they actually were, their sister always laughed at them because they turned red whenever the conversation turned to these topics. And now they were a fool following this man in a brothel...

„You must not have been working here for too long, because I would notice if another elf worked here...„ They heard and turned around, jumping in fear. To their utter surprise, they saw an elf standing next to them. She was probably a Moonshadow Elf, although it was hard to tell because her entire face was covered with a strange painting that made it look like she was wearing a porcelain mask. They weren't clear whether it was a tattoo or

makeup. She was so scantily clad that Rao felt their face turn red, especially since she was so attractive... Seeing their reaction, the Moon Elf laughed heartily.

„Oh, you definitely don't work here... That's good, because it's nice to be the only elven courtesan in the Human Kingdoms. You can call me Ghost.„ She said, smiling friendly. They felt sad because They understood what happened to that woman. They felt sorry for her.

„So you won't turn me in or do anything like that?” they asked and started to get up to go back to that room, but they realized that it would be occupied for some time so they were trapped here, at least until the three in room finished what they were doing. They couldn't go out on the street dressed like that, shame would kill them. And if it wasn't shame, Miriam would definitely do it.. Their friend certainly wouldn’t be happy that they wander around the city dressed as a courtesan, following the estate manager who probably owed her nothing.

„And what exactly is someone like you looking for in a place like this? You are pretty girl, but...”

„I am they/them, but in these clothes it's an understandable mistake.„ They said and Ghost blushed while explaining. „I followed Jaso but I didn't expect that he would go to such a place and now I'm trapped here, in a sense, because I came up with the idea of dressing up as one of the people working here, but I left my clothes in another room.„ They looked down in shame.

The elf smiled friendly at him and said.

„I can take you to my room. I don't work until the evening anyway, and since I'm a star here, so to speak, no one will cause any difficulties for me. If anyone asks, I'll tell you that I'm considering recruiting a new employee. „ when they hear the Moon Elf's words, they blushes even more. So the Ghost added. „ Okay, I won't say that, because you'll soon become some new Kind of elf... A Beetroot Elf or something like that. I'll just say I

don't know, grandpa's visiting or something like that, I'll think of something. Where did you leave your old clothes?„ She asked, giving him her hand, About where it was, and then the courtesan led them to her room. It was quite luxurious and lavishly decorated by elven standards, especially for the Moonshadow Elf. There were perfumes and cosmetics on the shelves. There was also a rich wardrobe here with many clothes, usually made of silk or transparent material. To their surprise, there were several books here as well. They opened one of them and immediately closed it. They couldn't say that the illustrations they saw there were as terrible as those books of dead names. They weren't terrible at all, and that's the point... They had to admit that, theoretically, you could learn a lot from them, but it wasn't the knowledge they wanted to acquire... At least now... Maybe one day they'll be able to use what they learns now. For example, if Miriam…. But no, she was just their friend... She wouldn't be anything to them anymore, no matter what they felt to her. Royal blood flowed in their veins, and they were just a Skywing Elf, even less, a common thief who tried to pass themselves off as a scholar. They sighed and put the book aside, it would be awkward if the Ghost saw them looking at something like that It did so just in time because the Moonshadow Elf entered. They must have looked particularly pathetic even for her, because she sat down on the bed next to then and asked.

„Why did you come here anyway? Because we've probably already established that you weren't looking for a job.”

They sighed and told the Ghost that it was with a friend and that the manager of the manor was dealing with suspicious matters, so it decided to follow it.

To their surprise, theGghost began to wonder and said.

„People of my profession like to gossip sometimes. Jaso doesn't come here for what everyone else does.. He apparently loves his deceased wife very much. You need to know that beneath this city is a huge labyrinth of tunnels built long ago, at a time when people were expelled to the west. Supposedly, when the

Pentarchy was born, they were intended to provide citizens with a safe place to hide in the event of a siege, but honestly, no one is sure what they were really intended for. I've been there several times, they are now used mainly by those who, for various reasons, want to be alone or do some business without the presence of others. It is said that Jaso meets with very suspicious people there, and his visits there are just a cover... If you really want, I can take you there to those tunnels.

They jumped with joy when it heard the woman's proposal.

„Yes, take me there! Please!„ they said pleadingly. The ghost laughed at his words and walked to the wall where she pressed something, revealing a very narrow staircase leading somewhere into the darkness. Without waiting for the Moonshadow Elf to run to that place, and despite the darkness and narrowness.

„Hey, what about your clothes?„ Moonshadow Elf called after him.

It was dark inside, so they had to light lanterns, but Klest seemed to be able to see in the darkness anyway. She moved through the halls of the Starboat as if its layout were familiar to her. She said herself that she wasn't worried about it at all, but it was lie There was something about this woman that made her every action suggest some terrible secret. At one point, they entered a large room with a large symbol made of a single piece of jade hanging on the wall. When she saw him, Klest smacked her lips with satisfaction and said.

„ So it's true... The Azlanti crashed on Xadia. If they founded this settlement, the history of the Erori family had a second, very dark and speciesistic meaning. If it is true that General Amay wants to marry Queen Janai, it will be an insult to the ancestors. Good old Gareth got married with someone with blood so pure. I wonder if he knew about it...„ the woman with scarlet hair laughed sarcastically under her breath. She frowned and asked.

„What is Azlanti? What are you talking about.” she felt confused by the things Klest was talking about, but scarlet haired woman snorted.

„Sweetie, it's better if you didn't know, although they wouldn't hurt you so much. It's worse with your Elf... Friend... „ she said, saying the word friend in a very meaningful way. She rolled her eyes and said.

„Rao and I are just friends, perhaps unusual, but we have nothing intimate in common.” she said a bit too energetically, so Klest smiled mockingly and they moved on.

Eventually she found herself in a room with many armchairs and several flat surfaces covered with a glassy substance. Somehow it reminded her of a council chamber in a castle, or a navigator's room on a ship.

„Excellent.” said Klest, and with a lightning-fast movement of her hand, she pulled out her gun, aimed it at the first of the men accompanying them, and then shot him. The gun didn't smoke, but the bang and flash momentarily deafened her and the other man. She knew that the woman with blood-colored hair should now abandon her weapon, since it was useless once fired, and reach for her dagger, but instead she aimed at her second opponent and fired again. The man fell dead and Klest cursed and said.

„Well, less than twenty left, I'll have to go get supplies soon.” she said and searched the body. Miriam recovered quickly, it wasn't the first time she witnessed death and screamed.

„Why did you do that!”

“I decided that this would be the best way to get rid of the spies. I preferred to do it without too much fuss. I can't trust all the people in my camp one hundred percent. Some of them I recruited quite recently, and others apparently too long ago and I'm not sure whether they were recruited by them.„ Klest

explained and put a few small items she found on the body into her pocket.

„Which ones are you talking about?„ Miriam asked, confused. She just hoped the woman hadn't gone completely mad. In a fit of paranoia, will she also consider her an enemy and try to kill her?

„About the friends of our, or rather your, friend Jaso? Although I'm not sure if he serves him directly. He's not as smart as he thinks.„ Klesti said, she took a small object from her pocket and then started to disassemble one of the strange devices standing in front of the armchair. She unscrewed a few screws, then removed the metal casing and began removing some parts. It looked a bit like she was taking the entrails out of a hunted animal. Finally she let out a short cry of pleasure and stood up.

„It's a pity it's Azlantean, because the operating systems are not compatible. I will have to bring the data manually, but it's not a problem. I'm finally leaving this shithole.”

„You mean Eastern Katolis?„ She asked suspiciously. Klest laughed.

„I mean fucking Xadia.„ Said the woman with scarlet hair and moved on. This time they wandered for a shorter time through the dark corridors. She finally made it to a large room and started pressing buttons on the wall. Suddenly, the light turned on and a voice spoke in a language she didn't know. Klest continued to press the buttons until a strange irritating sound was heard and the lights began to flash.

„Well, we've overloaded the reactor more, but it's better to be as far away as possible when everything goes to shit.„ Klest said and told her to follow her again. The way back was much faster. When they went outside, the bright light blinded her, and the woman with scarlet hair started talking to her subordinates.

„Unfortunately, Rick and Eze triggered an ancient trap that took their lives. They shielded us with their own bodies... Sadly a

powerful spell has also been activated that will soon blow up the Starboat and it would be good if we were far away! Grab only the most necessary things and on your feet.” and she took Miriam's arm and then pulled her along. The Dark Mage let out a short scream as terrible pain shot through her injured leg. She almost fell over, but Klest was so damn strong, so after a while she just picked her up. It was definitely a less painful way to travel, but what made her most uncomfortable was the fact that she could already hear the woman's stupid and pathetic attempts at flirting in her head. She finally set it down on the ground. She noticed that her camp was already intensively preparing to set out, apparently the artifact hunter had already given the appropriate orders in advance. But she wondered why all the rush. Whatever Klest did, it couldn't have threatened them at this distance... Or maybe it could? She wasn't sure, she didn't know anything about Starboats, although she was just beginning to realize that she had absolutely no understanding of what was going on around her.

Finally, she saw Krest's subordinates mounting mounts, mostly horses, but there were also these strange animals ridden by a pair of Moonshadow Elves... Or maybe they were siblings? It wasn't important now. What was much more important was that she now had a long ride ahead of her... She groaned, but then realized that they were not going back to the Erori family manor.

„Klest! Wait! Where are we going?” she asked the scarlet-haired woman,

„To Hammerhall Fortress... To my old friend... „ said Klest, packing hastily. She grabbed the woman's sleeve and said.

„I have to go back for Rao! I can't leave them here!” she exclaimed, truly terrified. Rao may not have been there at all

Klest raised an eyebrow and giggled.

„So you want also save your "friend"... I'm not surprised by this. They are so pretty! Your nights will be much lonelier without them! So you probably understand that you want to save them.

Yes, I will help you. I've always wanted to see a dark magician save a beautiful person! She said and turned to one of her people, the same one she talked to earlier, at the excavation site.

„ You know where to take the rest. I will leave you for now, I have a truly knightly quest to perform, and as the Squire I must accompany the dark mage on hers expedition! Don't get into unnecessary fights, if someone from the authorities bothers you, refer to Warhamer. Then no one will stand in your way. If I am not with you when you reach Grimm, then tell him that the fairest of the beautiful has found what they have been looking for for so many years. And if one of our opponents stands in your way, kill him without hesitation, everything will be explained later.„ she explained and chose two strange animals, it would be even worse than horse riding, and ordered her to ride one of them. Lidia was happy to do so and together they drove towards the town

Now Rao realized that they actually doesn't like the dark and if they think about it, they had quite severe claustrophobia. The latter was typical of their people, so fond of open spaces. Rao was also afraid of spiders, it was also justified, because several huge ones once tried to eat them, and they didn't like the dark either, because their eyesight was extremely sharp in the daylight, but in the dark they was almost blind. They had to rely on the Ghost to guide them, because as a Moonshadow Elf she could see in the dark and she coped perfectly. They didn't get fully dressed because they didn't want to waste any time. only threw a small cloak behind they back. They expected it to be very cold and humid, but to his surprise again, it was dry and quite warm.

„The Hot Springs are located beneath the town. Since the creation of the Border, many of them have appeared on both sides, and the inhabitants of this place decided to make use of them.„ Ghost explained to him. When I have my head and continued to follow her. Fortunately, both of them were able to move very quietly, which helped them a lot when they entered a large room illuminated by several extremely luminous crystals rare on this

side of the Border, the light of which was reflected in a shallow pool in the middle. The Ghost told them to stop immediately and be quiet. After a while they heard Jaso's voice.

„I think we might have a problem He turned to the person hiding in the shadows, whose tall and muscular figure was barely visible to Rao. „I didn't expect this girl to come here so quickly and be so interested in the excavations. I thought you would call by financing this venture and receiving small gifts from time to time. On top of that, she hired this strange woman with those scary eyes I thought. that she will take care of all this and she will get this ship out of the ground. At the beginning I thought that Klest was just a treasure hunter, but her people look well and only professional, but as if they had done similar things before. She knows about this matter, much more more than she says, because she even thinks she knows about our masters. About Great Old Ones and things like that... „ The steward's voice sounded as if the man was truly terrified. However, when the second voice spoke, they understood where this fear came from. They were itself afraid of who it belonged to.

„You idiot! You could have framed her for fraud or something, or you could have just reported her to someone in authority. You are de facto the king's cousin, you have some influence at the court, isn't it?" Khandros, the most dangerous man they had ever known, spoke hoarsely and impatiently. He was the one who mutilated them, took away its former life. He had stripped away part of their soul, turning them into the fearful creature they now were.

„Just look at these tattoos! He's a damn murderer!" whispered the courtesan.

„No... He's much worse." Rao whispered, their throat tight with fear. Although it couldn't see the Ghost, they felt that she was watching them.

"Do you know him?" she asked.

„ Yes... From another life.” They said quietly, barely audible. The Ghost didn't ask any more questions, after all, she could see the scars on their back. However, the men continued the discussion.

„I guess it doesn't matter what I could have done in the past but i didn't. All that matters is what we can do now.” The steward defended himself. Khandros, however, only growled and drawled...

„Not we, but you, because you were entrusted with the task of recovering this ship, and you couldn't even do it on your own. It doesn't matter now anyway, so you'll just have to get rid of this girl and her Elven companion.”

They heard Jaso take a deep breath and saw the man take a few steps back.

„Are you crazy! She is the cousin of Queen of Durren. If something happened to her, even by accident, the consequences could be terrible. Everything will be lost, there may even be a war. „ The steward's voices were pure astonishment and disbelief, Khandros however, laughed hoarsely and said.

„If you don’t solve this problem today, you will be dead. Choose between a possible war and a very certain and painful death... The choice is probably obvious, don't you think?”

Rao let out a short, muffled moan. They wanted to murder Miriam! Until now, they were afraid that Klest might pose a real threat to her. But Khandros! He would be a monster, the embodiment of all fears, the worst person ever. He couldn't hurt the one They loved! If that happens, then... They couldn't imagine what they would do then...

But Jaso laughed, bitterly and not happily, and spoke in a surprisingly hard voice.

„Do you think I'm doing all this for money? That I'm afraid of death? My only fear is that I will fail.. I am guided by Higher Goals. You, as far as I know, are just an ordinary murderer, working for someone who will allow him to shed blood and will

pay for it. Your own kin have condemned you to a fate worse than death! You are even outcasts among outcasts! I know you used to work for the Serpent Path until they found out about you... You don't think your new employers will quickly understand what a bastard you are!„ Jaso Now he started practically screaming. His words were listened to with understanding. It was at the command of the Serpent Path that they were mutilated! They wasn't certain whether what was more disturbing was that even that organization was disgusted by this Moonshadow Elf, or that he was about to find new employers who didn't care about his reputation. Khandros growled loudly and took a few steps into the grass, and toward Jaso and they heard him draw his blades.

„One more word, you bastard, and I'll feed you with your own insides.“ His voice convinced Rao that he would carry out his threats at the slightest provocation . They felt fear. They could imagine what this murderer might do to them and the woman with them if he found out they were eavesdropping on him.. Jaso however, just snorted, an unexpected courage came into this man.

„You're not the one passing judgment on this matter, Khandros! We both served beings greater and more magnificent than us! Or maybe you are unable to comprehend it with your mind? „ The steward started laughing, this time with a sense of superiority in his voice, as if he could cut the Moonshadow Elf into pieces at any moment, and not the other way around.

They never found out what Khandros wanted to do, because then a giant explosion shook the underground... Rao felt his shoulder hit the tunnel wall painfully, and the woman accompanying Them let out a short scream. Fortunately, Khandros did not hear them, as the sound of the shock drowned out everything.

„It's too late... This woman... She must have done something to this ship. Never mind. I have to get out of here, there are much more important matters than you, stupid man, as you have just seen. If you don't take care of it, the one with me will solve the problem. I was graciously offered the support of the Hunter and

his hounds..” although it didn't see the man, it was certain that he was smiling.

„Now we definitely have to run away from here, do you know where your friend is?„ asked the Ghost, they nodded in response and together they went to the brothel...

When she woke up in the carriage, she had no idea that she would miss it. These strange creatures were even worse than horses, and on top of that, Klest set them at a furious pace. The Woman with the Eyes of a Murderer seemed to be beaming with joy, though she wasn't sure whether it was the ride itself or the fact that her companion was going through torture. With this woman, both possibilities were equally likely. She had recently shot two men just because she had some doubts about their loyalty... She had a lot of sins on her conscience, but she hadn't murdered anyone in cold blood... At least not in this insidious way. But Klest was much more than a cold-blooded murderer and a ruthless treasure hunter. She knew about things that no one in all of Xadia knew about. Has she ever found another Starboat, or rather a spaceship as she called it? And her gun, she had never seen a weapon like that. At first it just seemed strange to her. Then it fired twice without reloading, which took so long. Is it like a magical artifact? A remnant from the old days? She heard from Rao on the theories of his master Prospero. He told a lot about Xadia's ancient past, which almost no one remembered anymore... For many, his theories were not even controversial, but even iconoclastic. She had also read about his deliberations. Prospero was a famous scientist, at least several decades ago. then, of course, he was expelled from the academy, but his words were not completely lost. She had heard about him before she met Rao. But that wasn't a sufficient explanation. There was no trace of delight in this woman's eyes when she was for the Starboat, as if it was a sight she was used to. Something she had seen many times before and was considered commonplace. As if she already…

She almost fell off her horse when she formulated that thought. She pulled on the reins and the Klest stopped.

„So you don't want to save your loved one? Decide that it would be a pity to have my mounts drive us one way and then the other. You know, I'm sure I could easily find you someone much better at these things... Like myself. You wouldn't have to drive so much and strain that bad leg of yours. „ Klest laughed loudly, but she did not allow herself to be provoked into a discussion, she asked directly.

„You've flown on the Starboat before, right?”

Klest laughed again and said.

„ Yes, I was not born on Xadi.a.. On this planet. My ship crashed here years ago and I've been trying to get out ever since. Okay, I'm not just trying to get out of here... I want to know the great secret here... I know that my family is somehow connected to it. I also know that it can have a huge impact on the fate of not only this planet, but also the entire Galaxy. You, the inhabitants of Xadia, cannot think on such a scale, both in time and space, but believe me. What will happen here may affect the lives of billions, hundreds, billions of beings... That's all I can tell you for now, if you want to know more, join me. Worst case scenario, you'll face an extremely interesting death, but at best, you will gain knowledge that even your greatest sages have never dreamed of.„ Klest smiled at her, assuming her predatory pose again. She sighed and replied.

„I just want to save Rao, nothing more... If you help me. then you can count on my gratitude... Within reason.„ She added, seeing the woman smiling at her.

„Well, to tell you the truth, we don't even know if they in any danger... But let's be honest. You're not looking for a Starboat, or perhaps as we should now say, a spaceship, just out of pure scientific curiosity. Oh no! Someone like you, the queen's cousin, doesn't become a dark wizard just because she's bored.. I know

what happened to you and I see how you suffer. You are looking for a remedy for your condition, and not only for your injured leg. It's more than that, isn't it? I smell death... death and darkness... And you, pretty one, smell of both. I don't know if even with the knowledge, technology and magic that is available throughout the galaxy, I will be able to help you, but I am giving you a chance. This is much more than your cousin the Queen has given you... Think about that as we ride towards the court.„ Said the woman with scarlet hair and spurred her horse, which galloped forward. She stared at her for a moment. You knew this woman was right. Everything she had been doing for two years was dictated by the fact that she wanted to find a cure for her condition... She was ready to do a lot, a lot, almost anything, to become the same as before. If it involved working with Klest, she was willing to go for it…. So she hurried her horse and also set out for the manor

When they reached the Manor, everything actually seemed to be fine. The servants went about their business. No one paid much attention to Klest. Certainly because the cold-eyed woman had visited Jaso more than once, And now everyone expected that he was going to discuss the excavations with him again. Jaso was nowhere to be found, he must have gone to an inn, casino or brothel, most likely the latter. She didn't care what this man did, but his absence might make things easier for them. The problem was that Rao was nowhere to be found either. She checked their room, where she couldn't find it, and ignored Klest's comments about them sharing one room, and then asked the servants to look around. However, no one knew where the Skywing Elf might be. Some said they went to the garden, but that was all she could find out about it. She swore several times under her breath. She was close to panic. The guards began to look askance as she screamed out loud, but Klest's strange look made them stay out of her way. She finally entered the library. The room was surprisingly well-equipped for a private manor. she saw a side door leading to a small room, and in her experience, such places were where the most valuable volumes were kept. The door was open, although it had a lock, which confirmed her suspicions and indicated that Rao

had gotten in. They were always curious and liked to go where he was allowed, and they were a better burglar than they let on. Together they looked inside, and Klest, as soon as she saw the name of one of the volumes. that were in the chest, she whistled and said.

„Necronomicon, or rather its truncated fragments... People will probably never learn not to use poor translations.

„What kind of book is this? Is it about dark magic?„ She asked, looking at one of the illustrations which depicted an extremely terrifying monster. The woman with the eyes of a murderer giggled and said.

„ Yeah, very dark, but not the kind you use. This elven person probably came in here and got scared when they saw this. it would be funny if they went looking for us in the city or, even funnier, at the excavation site. The latter, however, may end badly.”

She gritted her teeth and grabbed the woman by her vest.

„Shut up! Don't you dare joke like that! Not with Rao! You can't even imagine what they went through! You don't have a heart, just a piece of ice!”

Klest giggled again and leaned over her. She was taller than her and much stronger... At this close, she was able to break her neck before she could cast the spell... Though she had other abilities as well, although she wasn't sure if she could use them against this woman... She couldn't fully control them, and Besides, Klest seemed so formidable that she wouldn't be surprised if she was able to defeat the Moonshadow Elf Assassin in a sword fight.

„My own Mother tried to sacrifice me to the lord of evil just to get revenge on my father, so sweetie I can imagine a lot... and as for my heart... I belong to a family of murderers who are only good at two things. Killing and spreading Chaos, so forget about such moralizing talk.” Klest whispered.

She blinked twice when she heard the woman's words. This wasn't the kind of confession she expected from this woman, although honestly she wasn't sure what she should expect from her. She didn't understand anything anymore, her whole world, everything she believed in fell apart. However, she knew that she should react somehow to Klest's words, but before she could think of anything, something shook the entire building. She heard the crash of broken windows and the woman with scarlet hair smiled proudly.

„I told you it fuck-ap, and it fuck-ap. Let's go see what's going on outside."

Slightly confused, she ran after the scarlet-haired woman. On the way, she had to watch out for broken glass and terrified servants... From what she noticed, several of them were injured, although she had no idea how seriously... She didn't have time for that... They found themselves in the garden and both immediately looked in the direction they came from. There was a huge cloud of smoke and dust floating there, somewhat reminiscent of a Mushroom.

"Don't worry, pretty onel. it was a plasma reactor, so the amount of radiation will be minimal."

„Radiation? What are you talking about again?" She asked irritably.

„Such great and evil magic that would make your hair fall out and your bones rot... It would be an irreparable tragedy!" the woman with scarlet hair shouted. And then they heard a yelp.

Miriam began to look around. Were they terrified Wolves or other predators? This explosion probably caused panic among all the animals many kilometers away. They could also be enraged... I guess. She didn't really know anything about animals or wildlife. She was a girl raised in one of the richest courts in the world, where hunting was never fashionable anyway. Shouldn't wolves be afraid of such a gathering of people? Then she looked at Klest and

saw Fear on her face and realized that the situation was really bad.

„What could it be?„ she asked the cold-eyed woman.

„It could be many thin things, but I guess it's the Huntsman's hounds... Fucking hell!”

Rao had money... Miriam gave them a purse full of human coins, And she also bought him a lot of jewelry... They rarely took them off, although they was not vain. Well, they wasn't very vain. They liked nice clothes and good food, it liked human culture in general, but they did not parasitize the queen's cousin... However, they had something to pay for the quick transport to the manor. The truth was that they wasn't easy to find someone willing to take them out of the town. The explosion caused panic among the residents, which was understandable. As soon as they saw a cloud of smoke dust on the horizon, they were honestly scared. They had no idea what could have happened, but they must have been something truly terrifying... No one wanted to hear about selling or abandoning their mounts at a time like this, especially not an elf.. Fortunately, the Ghostt helped them. The Elven courtesan had her own mount, and it was a Xadian creture, one of those strange cats with blue-green fur... So he was very happy when Moonshadow Elf offered to lend them her mount... The problem was that they had absolutely no knowledge of riding a horse. After all, for most of their life it needed to ride animals, at least those on the ground. Until… that moment, they were free to roam the skies. Then it usually traveled by carriage or ship, because of Miriam's leg. The Ghost sighed at his efforts not to fall off the animal, and then she said.

„I'll go with you, because you'll kill yourself on the way.„ she said and got on the horse. „Just hug me and hold me tight!”

They did as she said. They wrapped themselves around the Moonshadow Elf and hugged her back as tightly as they could.

„You know, it would be a bit more comfortable and definitely less awkward if you dressed up”. Ghost said uncertainly.

„I didn't have time! I have to save Miriam!„ They cried, trying to sound firm, although it turned purple with shame. The ghost shook her head and they ran towards the Erori manor

„Which Hunter and Hounds are you talking about!” Miriam exclaimed angrily, wanting to cover her fear with anger. Klest She looked around nervously as the people of the manor huddled together, even more scared than before.

„Hunters are servants of Lord Tholuvian, one of the aspects... It doesn't matter... As long as the sun shines, they won't do anything to you.” said Klest and looked up. „So in the next ten minutes...”

She looked up. A cloud of dust from the blown-up ship was approaching and would soon cover the sun. Something had to be done... Fortunately, she was very good at managing people. After all, she was of royal blood and had been taught from childhood to lead others, even if she was not to take the throne.

„Listen! Everyone go to the manor immediately and we will barricade ourselves there against what is coming. Don't be afraid, they're just feral dogs... We'll handle it just fine... Miss Klest is a great fighter and will stop the Beasts without any effort. However, we have to hurry, because this type of hound attacks only after dark, and as you can see, this cloud will soon cover the sun.„ She pointed to the sky, where the dust cloud was getting closer and closer to the Sun circle. She had so much authority in her voice that the all servants listened to her. Unfortunately, barricading was difficult due to broken windows, they will have to set up on the stairs and hope that no one will jump to the first floor. Frightened People willingly followed her orders, except, of course, Klest, who was playing nervously with a dagger and this strange gun, looking out the window with slight fear.. And then there was Darkness and

a howling sound. She reached into her bag of magical ingredients and prepared to cast Spells. Unlike her homeland, dark magicians were respected in Katolis, and in the face of such danger, everyone forgot their prejudices. There was a similar howl and then another, and three huge hairy Beasts fell into the main living room. They were as big as small horses, with their legs spread wide apart like a spider's. Their snouts were much more elongated than those of a true hound, more reminiscent of the aquatic predatory reptiles of Evenere.

„They were created as Echo Memories of long-extinct predators, But these are not ordinary animals.„ Klest whispered in her ear and drew her weapon, holding it in both hands. She fired twice at the first of the hounds and hit him, although the wounds was not serious and the Beast began to bleed a strange green ichor. Two more flew towards them, covering a distance with incredible speed.. She crushed the spider and spoke the words of the spell, then threw the flame at one of the attacking monsters. The effect exceeded her wildest expectations. Flame enveloped the monster and the Beast fell to the ground, turning to ash in the blink of an eye. However, the dear creature jumped between them. He somehow tore apart a stocky woman, probably a roommate, but Klest attacked him with her dagger. She stuck it into the beast's neck and it was sharpened with blue fire. Then Miriam began to weave another spell. Her hands have transformed into long, sickle-shaped blades like those of a praying mantis or other insect. They went back to the monster's neck, covering everything with disgusting blood. Then a woman with scarlet hair threw her over the railing. She had to admit that her ally was a person with extraordinary, even superhuman strength. Then The monster who was the first to receive wounds from Klest's gun, got to his feet but instead of attacking, he retreated to the door. They heard slow, respectful clapping from that direction. And then a voice rang out, that is, it seemed to come from everywhere, from every shadow, as if its owner was standing right next to their ear.

„That was interesting. I expected that my nice friends would tear you apart almost immediately, without much effort... And here

you are. You defended yourself from these puppies... I am the Hunter Kerankan of gloves, it will be an honor to skin you.

Then a man entered the living room. He was extremely tall, over two and a half meters tall and apart from that he looked almost like an ordinary hunter. However, his eyes. they seemed to be larger than those of an ordinary person... They radiated white, or maybe rather white-blue, light, like the disk of the moon. It seemed almost artificial, as if someone had put crystal balls in their heads. He was armed with a long knife as if made. from some Claw and a whip that moved on its own. Miriam did not wait for the reaction of this strange, terrifying creature, but cast another spell. The floor beneath her exploded and thousands of splinters flew into stranger. The creature let out a strange hissing cry, and then Klest began to utter words. It sounded like she was casting a spell, but she didn't recognize the language the woman was speaking

„An ancient language... This place doesn't look like one where anyone knows him... Or maybe... My brothers and sisters were here once. a long time ago and not very often, but still... But these words are enough to stop me... We know you... You were supposed to be a gift to our Lord... He will reward you in exchange for your soul... „ And he began to slowly walk towards them. She uttered another spell, and this time a black flame shot out from her staff, which she usually leaned on. The man stopped, but did not burn in an agonizing cry, as happens with an ordinary mortal. He covered himself with this strange coat. Only now did the Dark Mage realize that it was made of faces... Human and otherwise... He took one step, and then another. It is not known what would have happened if Rao had not appeared at the door... In front of them was a strange stone carved with a green and blue pattern that glowed with a soft light..

„No... You can't be here! You have to leave, do you understand?! I... I command you! „ Rao exclaimed. The symbol began to burn and the hunter cringed.

„I will obey this command... I could not oppose what this thing is... Then my Lord will be my replacement. Lord Tholuwian… He'll be here soon! „ And the Huntsman broke up into a swarm of frail birds, probably nightjars. Hound turned into a shadow and ran away as well. Miriam sighed heavily, despite her triumph. A woman, probably a Moon Elf, followed Rao inside... She immediately made Miriam suspicious. She quickly came down the stairs and hugged Rao.

"It's good that nothing happened to you. You don't even know how happy I am about this." Then she saw the outfit Rao wore under the cloak. They were almost naked, and what she wore only emphasized their… advantages. "Where were you exactly?" she asked suspiciously.

„Because I went to a brothel and changed into someone's clothes there, and then the Ghost took me to her room...„ said Skywing Elven person.

„What!?„ she asked indignantly, and Klest, standing behind her, snorted with amusement.

„It wasn't supposed to sound like this... I'll explain everything to you later... Now I think... I think we should run away from here, because I don't like the words that man said there..."

„And rightly so... Come with me, and I promise that this vice will be characters you haven't even dreamed of.„ said Klest

„I'm also coming with you... If the Serpent Path is involved... Then I have reasons to help you. „ said the Elf who was brought by Rao... She gritted her teeth angrily and felt a piercing pain in her leg. It's going to be a long journey.

Chapter End Notes

And the next chapter, I remind you that googletranslate has a problem with Rao's Pronouns. The Hunter was inspired by the Hunter from Loop Hero.

Crossroads of Fate

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She woke up and saw her wife 's face staring at her with concern. You smiled at your lover and replied.

„This is one of the nicest views you can imagine after waking up.„ She said and stood up on the bed. It was daytime and she was dressed in her usual clothes, although they had been changed. Nothing hurt her. She was only a little tired, but it was quite good considering… Now she remembered what had happened and felt a sudden surge of fear. She wanted to jump to her feet, but Catra stopped her.

„Relax. It's over now.„ The cat girl said in a reassuring tone. She immediately noticed that she didn't say everything was fine. You felt icy claws squeezing her heart.

„Has anyone... has anyone else died?„ She asked, trembling at the thought of what she might hear. But her lover shook her head and said.

„ Only the guards, but you saw them... Klementine is save and sound... As possible as you can be after being dead... This priestess will probably seriously start praying to you now” She laughed a little nervously, but hearing about the prayers made her feel cold. She remembered those voices... What they said... What they demanded of her...

„What about Lady Cala and Shadow Weaver?„ She asked, trying to change the subject. Her wife pursed her lips.

„ They escaped... All three of them and that monster. No one knows where they are, I personally suspect they went to Castle Crypto, But I can't be entirely sure... Scorpia, Perfuma , Mermista and... Frosta are safe and sound. „ You smiled, although she hesitated when she mentioned the ice princess.

„And Glimmer? Has she regained her connection to the moonstone?„ She asked, but her wife shook her head.

„Not yet, But she's fighting... It was Nightgale who took it in... She killed Brother Blade... He was good... He always wanted to prove that clones could be more than just soldiers... than executors of their Horde Prime’s will... He tried so hard to show it to everyone, and she killed him. She is her daughter... This explains everything... Evil lives in her. She lived among us... She hid what she was... They are the same. Nightgale and Shadow Weaver... I don't know if we did the right thing by letting Hordak go . He knew he had another daughter... He hid it from everyone... Even from his wife. I know Entrapta will forgive him. She even forgave me in the end. However, I believe that we should not do this.„ Her wife shook her head as if to drive away unwanted thoughts. She hugged her, knowing that she still hadn't forgiven herself for what had once done to the inventor, and that she would never forgive the former ruler of the Horde for what he forced them all to do.

„We'll deal with that later. We should deal with current problems, dear... do we already know what Comrade General intends to do?„ She asked, addressing both herself and wife.

Catra shook her head.

„We don't know anything about her... Or about my sister... You know, this time I was such idiot. I should have asked Shadow Weaver about her... I was so angry. So angry that I forgot about my old girlfriend... She's out there somewhere... You saw her then, right? It wasn't a hallucination? Who is this other girl? Why did she want to kill you? You didn't do anything to her?„ Her beloved said. She was visibly shaken. She flattened her ears and

wagged her tail nervously which became erect. Her companion paced around the room as nervous as Catra…

„I guess we need to focus on the People's Rebellion first. They have an Empress and more... Entrapta and your sister are there too. Apart from that. The dark sorceress also cooperated with them... „ she turned to her beloved, trying to comfort her, although she was absolutely exhausted herself.

„What about you?„ Her wife asked. She smiled weakly at her.

„I'm fine... It's just very exhausting trying to bring someone life back.„ She laughed, fully aware that the cat girl wouldn't believe her, but what could she tell her? That strange voices were telling her to leave or do something even worse…

„This priestess... She is delighted with you. I do not like it. I don't like it when others treat you this way... As if you weren't yourself... As if you belonged to them. Because you are mine, only mine. And it will always be like that, right?„ She saw a pleading in her beloved's eyes that she hadn't expected. As if her beloved desperately wanted confirmation that she would never leave her... She understood that, after all, she had already done it to her once. But she had a feeling there was more to it. As if her wife was afraid of something. Something new that she hadn't told her yet.

„Of course it will always be with you, darling... But you don't have to be jealousI will always be only yours. „ She kissed her and they both hugged.

„But sooner or later Glimmer will have to do something about it Forbid others from worshiping you... And it's not that I feel jealous, because I don't. Well, maybe a little. In my opinion this is dangerous and inappropriate. It's too much like Him. People shouldn't look at others like that. It's like they're giving up a part of themselves, you know? They're like these clones. As if they wanted to deny themselves to please someone else who doesn't care about them anyway. It's not just about you. At least you are

real, but about all of them. And also this priest of Hylax . Did you hear what terrible things he said about Frosta? And she probably started to believe him in his nonsense.„ She bristled when she told about Shirren. To her, that person seemed quite nice. But she was never good at judging people. After all, she believed for years that Shadow Weaver cared about her.

„How about Frosta ... Is she feeling better already?„ She asked, afraid of the answer. Catra hesitated before answering.

„That spel that Nightgale cast ... It killed Brother Blade, but didn't do anything to Frosta. She is very worried about this. She thinks there is something wrong with her. But it's just a matter of her magic... It's probably her runestone that works this way. She was always the most resilient of us.. I tell her this, but she doesn't listen. Maybe if you told her something, calmed her down and told her everything was fine..... „ Catra looked her straight in the eye. For a moment she wanted to promise that she would, but then she remembered what happened when she touched the younger girl. She then screamed in pain, as if the very touch was burning her. She, too, sensed something strange about Frosta A cold darkness that seemed to envelop her soul. There was something extremely wrong about it. She couldn't describe it exactly, but she had seen something like it before, in that dream... This being, Charon emanated it. She didn't want to tell Catra about it though. Not now… Her wife had a harder time accepting Frosta's condition than the ice princess herself. It was probably because she blamed herself for what happened to her. She understood well , because she herself often felt guilty for what happened to others. But sooner or later everyone will have to come to terms with what happened to the girl.

„Stay with me. Let's get some rest and maybe we'll figure out what to do next. Let's just be together. Let's forget about the whole world.

In response, Catra snuggled closer to her and began to purr. Immediately afterwards, both of them sank into the blissful oblivion of sleep.

After receiving new instructions from the Creeping Chaos, she felt overwhelmed by the amount of work ahead of her. Three women and an eldritch monster They had to cooperate and coordinate their efforts to achieve the goal. Or maybe the goals... They have to separate. She didn't mind the fact that she and Lady Cala would part ways. To be honest, they had always hated each other, she only realized how much after they had been separated for several weeks and when she had cooperated with the People's Rebellion. Although she had spent the last few years training the young aristocrat, they had never formed a bond... Lady Cala was unable to form any bond with a normal being... Because Blackwind was probably not one of them. So she was secretly glad that they would be separated again. But that was the only thing she was happy about.

She had to be separated from her daughter, although she was in a very difficult condition. She remembered well how she felt when she was in a similar situation. The suffering she experienced was difficult to describe, but she still managed to gain a position in the Horde. However, she was then a mature woman with a hardened heart, and Nightgale was still a sensitive girl who longed for love and acceptance. She didn't want to leave her alone. This alternating euphoria and torment was debilitating. She didn't want this girl to become someone like her, she wanted to protect her from everything that awaited her, but she couldn't... She had to return to her homeland... That was the second thing that fueled her frustration. She hadn't been there in over seventy years. She left them convinced that she would never return there. She hated and despised that place. For as long as she could remember, she wanted to get out of there, and in the end, she would return there anyway... But not with her tail between her legs.

Lady Cala sat casually on the veranda and drank wine from General Juliette's supply . She suspected that this inhuman abomination took pleasure in consuming the drink belonging to the family she had wronged so much. Nightgale sat on a wicker chair with her arms around herself. Chills shook her body. She

walked up to her and hugged her. She didn't say anything because it didn't make sense anyway. There was no point in saying anything in such a situation. Lady Cala saw this and let out a short laugh.

„When I was little, my mother sometimes hugged me. I never understood what she meant. I even wondered if he was secretly trying to strangle me. Only later did I realize that mortals sometimes do this. To be close or something like that. In this way, they wanted to strengthen social bonds. Making the other person feel safe and loved. I am invincible, so I always feel safe, And mortals will never love me as they should.„ she said and giggled. Her voice was nervous and shaky. From time to time she spoke with Nyarlathotep, she seemed shocket. If she had known this was possible, she would have suspected that the girl was worried or terrified... She also saw bottles on the side... In fact, she wasn't sure how creatures like her reacted to alcohol. In many ways she was very human, although she would never admit it...

„But you're not alone. You have siblings, perhaps even extended family. Do you also feel connected to each other, like all beings?„ Nightgale asked. Lady Cala snorted contemptuously.

„We are not like other beings. Each of us is an amazing and unique creature, we cannot be compared to each other! Do the Gods form one big family?„ She growled, but the younger sorceress said with a wry smile.

„You are absolutely perfect, awesome and unique, aren't you?

At first, the aristocrat nodded, only after a while she realized that Nightgale refers to a saying often uttered by Eti. Lady Cala jumped to her feet and looked at her daughter.

„How dare you compare me to this creature!„ She overtook it, but Nightgale looked at her hard.

„Because you are much more similar than it might seem at first glance... You were both created for one purpose. All of you were

only tools intended to fulfill the will of those at whose command you were created... All three of you are similar. You, Eti and Catra. All three of you are unique, although they are more unique than you. You and the great Marshal always want the recognition that others do not give you. Your emotions are also different from the rest of society... And each of you is not quite what you want to be."

For a moment she was convinced that Lady Cala would attack her daughter and you would tear her apart. But the aristocrat sank into a chair and laughed nervously.

"You're right, little witch. If I were better. If only she tried harder. If only I had been luckier, this place would not have been visited by Evangeline." She rubbed her hair with her hands.

To change the topic, she asked.

„Who is Evangeline?"

„She's one of my sisters, but you've already guessed that... She's older, much older than me. She was born on the lost Golarion. She and her twin sister, Demonique ... Only the latter chose a more human nature while Evangeline embraced divinity. She was imprisoned for centuries in their family estate, which was moved to the Nightmare Plateau of Leng. I only met her once, in a dream. She... I awe mortals by showing them what they really are, miserable vermin standing in the way of the goddess. However, I can only kill and maim in battle, and Evangeline ... She loves other beings with a love that is as deep as it is twisted. She distorts bodies and minds and calls it love. A bit like you Shadow Weaver, but she truly believes in what she does. She is not like Horde Prime, there is no arrogance or hypocrisy in her, only love and madness... Love and madness.„ Lady Cala looked ahead, absorbed in reflection, and in that one moment, for the first time in the five years of their acquaintance, she saw a bit of humanity in this young woman.

Then she looked at the bottle of wine. She felt an overwhelming desire to reach for it and empty it. All of this made her addiction come back, but truth be told, It never left her. It was a substitute for the power she had always wanted as well. A way to escape self-hatred and the awareness of her own failure... It made it much easier for her to hurt those who wanted her love, but she couldn't quite hold her addiction responsible for her evil deeds. While on Carurystal, alcohol allowed her to forget the dark blade hanging over her, what she would have to do, and the inhuman creature she helped train. But now she realized that this was not the path she should have taken She couldn't let her mind cloud, it had to be as sharp as a sword of protection. Even though she suffered because of what happened to her daughter, she could not escape into alcoholic oblivion. She had to face reality, otherwise she would lose everything and even more than everything. So she looked away from the bottle and turned to the other women.

„What are we going to do now? I will go to the Isles of Sorrow, that may be difficult in itself, although I have some idea on how I can get there. I know that my sisters are in some way favorable to us. „ When she said this, the daughter nodded and said.

„Yes, Midnight Mask helped the People's Rebellion, but she serves someone else... She is an acolyte of Zon-Kuthon, although I don't know much about him.” Nightgale said, and she added thoughtfully.

„Lord of the Midnight , a dark deity who rules pain and darkness. From what I heard, he used to be a different being, but he was corrupted when he went to a place inhabited by the Great Old Ones... It's hard to say why he is on the side of the Creeping Chaos, Maybe, because the victory of the First Ones also means the end of suffering, or at least its significant reduction. I'm just not sure to what extent my sister serves him sincerely, and to what extent he tempted her by fueling her jealousy and lust for power... or whether she simply likes his nickname. I never expected that the followers of the gods would reach Etheria so quickly, especially my homeland... Cults are different, as far as I

know, the followers of the Old Ones have always operated in secret, and their rulers do not care about the number of servants or spreading the faith in them. They only want to achieve their unknown goals... It might be interesting to meet my mother and your grandmother after so many years... Perhaps it would be good if they met you, but not in these circumstances... „ She smiled sadly at both women and asked. “What are you going to do?” she looked after her daughter and at her charge. Nightgale was the first to respond..

„I have to go to Castle Crypto I left some of my things behind, and besides, this castle holds a few more secrets that I was afraid to explore before, but now I desperately need answers... I suppose I can gain knowledge there on how to get to Xadia. And besides... I have to say goodbye to Lonnie and the rest somehow. I have lived with them for the last few years. They are my friends, although I never planned for them to become so. Until now I realized how important they are to me. I don't know if they would accept me as I am now, but they showed me a lot of heart. You saw them yourself. They are honest at heart. They just directed their anger in the wrong way. I owe them at least a proper goodbye, and there's one more thing... Kyle, he 's …Well...„ Her daughter was strangely confused.

„Your boyfriend? You know, he lives in quite a complicated relationship with Lonnie and Rogelio.„ She didn't finish because Nightgale interrupted her.

„None of these things. I slept with Lonnie sometimes, but it wasn't anything serious. Kyle has a second sword. Like Adora... He's someone just like her. He also has power... I don't know why. I haven't investigated this matter properly. He wasn't very keen either, you can guess why... Now we won't do anything about it.”

She felt her jaw drop and she must have looked extremely idiotic.

„But Kyle? He's a lubber after all. He never succeeded in anything. This is a man who tripped over his own feet. So, looking at my other mistakes, he must also be a prince of power, something like

that. My life is one great irony. But, let's leave this topic. Is your informant…”

„Aaravos. That's how I contacted him. The first time was that night after our meeting in Mystacor. I performed a certain ritual so that I don't have to use the mirror to talk to him...” She pointed to the strange larva-like creature in her ear. “So he showed me how to conduct the ritual of obtainment... Although, as you can see, even his advice didn't help much.”

The being, because the word person definitely didn't describe what he was, that the Crawling Chaos had mentioned. The creature he told them to release.. She saw him when her daughter summoned the Devourer of Light. This individual was co-responsible for all the evil she had done and suffered. It all started with him. She felt an overwhelming wave of hatred towards the elven sorcerer flare up in her heart . But she immediately extinguished it, because a plan was already sprouting in her heart.....

„I saw him too, actually I see him all the time. I guess it's because of my divine origin. After all, he is the chosen one of the Great Nyarlathotep. He seems like a very interesting person. I can't wait until I can talk to him. It is our duty as people with noble hearts to free him, and yet there is no doubt that ours are so... Or at least Mine.„ She laughed brilliantly. „ When Nightgale finds out everything, let her travel with me... If I have to help her with her problem, it's probably good for us to be close to each other, isn't it?”

She narrowed her eyes and regarded the noblewoman suspiciously, but Nightgale nodded.

„Yes, that sounds reasonable. But where will you go?” she asked Lady Cala , who smiled.

„To the Singing Jungle, I guess. Kranor Rill is located there.”

„Another?” she asked, surprised. These Swamps also existed on Carurystal. Memories were associated with the expedition she organized to explore these cursed swamps... Painful memories, even doubly so now after what had recently happened... She remembered her last, yes, truly last, conversation with Asindesa di Vir and felt an overwhelming sadness flooding her heart. However, she composed herself and looked at Lady Cala , who began to explain.

„Just like in many other places throughout the Galaxy. Maybe Bloodstone can be installed there, and if not, at least I'll get Riliti to our cause.” the eldrithh monster with the face of a beautiful aristocrat smiled.

„If you find any there. I haven't heard many stories about frog-like monsters invading the inhabitants of Etheria. The First Ones probably murdered them, and I don't blame them. These creatures have no real intelligence anyway, and they live only to kill or to serve „ it's hard to say.„ There were traces of her old anger in her voice, resulting from powerlessness.

„They must be so wonderful, isn't they?„ The young aristocrat asked, smiling slyly.

„Hey, that just made them even more likely to be murdered by Horde Prime. He had the means, and more importantly the desire, to do something like this. The mindless resistance that Rilliti would put up would greatly encourage him to exterminate... It might have been the only good thing he had done for this world. „ She drawled with irritation. Horde Prime was a bastard, but she would totally understand if he wanted to get rid of that bloodstone remnant.

Then Nightgale spoke

„ He wants me to give you something, his knowledge. Well, I didn't perform the ritual that allowed me to talk to Star Saihe so that I wouldn't benefit from his knowledge now„ Her daughter said, smiling bitterly

Nightgale was so tired, but she also knew this was only the beginning. The power still pulsed through her veins. She managed to keep control of the Moonstone. Hey, I saw that it seemed to take forever for you, it's good, they had to hurry instead of arguing.

„He says the swamps here have been almost cleared. There was a fully developed Bloodstone here, but it was destroyed by Mara after what happened to the original inhabitants of this planet. It was one of the last. Maybe even the penultimate one. There aren't many frog-like monsters left. But they left the console intact... First Ones left it for research purposes. They want to study the structure of the energy grid in order to use it later, which as you know they have done on this planet and probably many others. Much more promising are the swamps on his world, in a country called Evenere... The colony there was almost developed, it only lacks real bloodstone. But this actually helped it survive. If you pull out the console from the local Bloodstone and live this truncated fragment of yours, you may be able to recreate a fully functioning structure. And that will give you great power. All Kranor Rills were connected by portals. So whoever finally creates Bloodstone, even the damaged one you are planning, will take over all the swamps, but Miss Cala probably already knows that, right?„ She repeated word for word what Aaravos told her. He is already next to her, as always, smiling mysteriously, as if he knew a secret that no one else knew. There was something irritating yet intimidating about this men. She felt no sympathy for him and wasn't sure if she hated him for the way he used her to perform the ritual of obtainment. He used her like lab rat. But he still commanded overwhelming respect thanks to his knowledge and skills. He was the chosen one of Nyarlathotep. He remembered the First Ones and fought with them and even won the victory. It was something that couldn't be ignored. So when he asked her to speak on his behalf and not resist, he was finally committed to this whole grand enterprise, as the Creeping Chaos Themselves said.

Her mother looked sternly at where she thought the Elder Sorcerer was, which Aaravos smiled softly at, and said.

„Yes, I completely forgot that there were four of us talking, together with our highly respected guest.„ there was barely audible hatred in her voice, which Aaravos didn't care about, because he started giving further orders through her.

"At the moment of their fall, the First Ones were close to creating a network of interplanetary portals. They did not achieve success, but their project was continued by certain factions. Here on Etheria , this project has been attempted twice. The sorcerers of Umbracor once tried to do this and almost succeeded , but a war broke out... Very sad and, to be honest, completely unforeseen by me... You really have to believe me, it was not my goal to destroy this wonderful university, because it thwarted my plans. That was one of the biggest disappointments that ever happened to me, the second was your failure.„ When he said this, Shadow Weaver tightened her hands on the table, but did not comment on the elven sorcerer's touch. „It was supposed to be quite efficient, allowing larger groups of people to be brought in at any time. The second one was located on today's Sorrow Islands... Their inhabitants always wanted to return to their former homeland, or at least get off this planet. They tried another way to bypass the restrictions of being in Despondos. They attempted to use shadow plane for this purpose Your dark sorceress might like this... Before you ask why you haven't heard about it, well, the whole project was considered heresy and all participants were killed. From what I know, in an extremely brutal way... This was my doing, I didn't want a bunch of angry warriors with a very rigid moral code to burst into my yard. However, in the current situation, I would welcome them. Because as you both know, we're running out of time. „ He finished repeating what the saihe sorcerer told her and added from herself. „He's definitely right about this.„ She said, looking at the two women who were slowly losing their heads. „I suggest that Shadow Weaver go to Xadia. Let her find Klaudia, the young dark magician who started cooperation with me. Her father is extremely valuable to us, but sadly, he had an accident some time ago, very similar to the one that happened to Shadow Weave

. Unfortunately, his resurrection will be much more difficult than yours, because he has not sold his soul to the Creeping Chaos yet. That's why someone has to help his daughter. She is full of enthusiasm, but very clumsy, to put it mildly. Even with my help, he may not be able to cope, especially since in the place where she lives humans can cast spells under certain restrictions
Therefore, she will need the help of someone who was famous throughout the planet for his skills in educating young people. Although some might debate this from what I've heard.„She didn't repeat Star Saihe's grim laugh to Mother

„Indeed, I will tell her everything I know. I have many more Skills than just knowledge of Spells."

Aaravos agreed with the dark sorceress, and stopped smiling mysteriously and most of the issues had already been discussed, but she remembered something and added.

„There is one more thing. Lonnie has made contact with Mi-Go, I think we could be an interesting alternative for them to working with the Rebellion."

Lady Cala raised an eyebrow and said.

„Are they here? This is very interesting... Did they survive for so many years when the planet was imprisoned, or did they only arrive recently?„ You could hear genuine interest in her voice

„From what they say, and we don't know how much we can trust these types of creatures, they have been here for a very long time, since the times of the First Ones or maybe even longer. Their population was wiped out by the previous She-Ra, although it is difficult to say whether Mara deserves this title. They agreed with Comrade General that they would help her recover an ancient ship hidden in a glacier. This may also be useful to us. So I guess we've covered everything, right? „ She asked and both women and the wizard, visible only to her, nodded.

„Once again, there's one more thing we need to decide at the end „ Lady Cala said at the end „ We'll split into three groups, but we only have two mirrors... How will we split?

„What mirrors? What are you talking about?„ She looked at the others, curious despite the waves of pain that shot through her body.

„ A gift from the Lord Admiral that he forgot to take back.. They aare the work of Krellans, creators of Bloodstone. They enable communication over huge distances, which is virtually impossible to overhear.„ The aristocrat explained.

„Take one, Calamity, because unfortunately you don't know magical forms of communication. If you decide to travel together, it is logical for me to take the second one..„ Shadow Weaver said. „ That's probably all, we're operating on borrowed time anyway. Soon the Queen should regain enough strength to find us using more conventional means, perhaps even transport others to where we are. I have a way to get to the islands, although it may not be very pleasant, neither for me nor for my wonderful sisters. Unfortunately, you have to cope on your own and use the contacts you have. „ Her mother sighed heavily and got up from the table. „ We will meet in two days at eight in the morning. You, Nightgale, will have to astral project yourself near me. Take a lock of my hair. „ Shadow Weaver Using a knife, she cut a few strands of her long black hair and handed them to her. and then proceeded to cast the spell.

Lady Ka looked at her new metal arm with a smile. She liked it. In some ways it was better than the old one. She was no longer surprised at her father that when his body was starting to fail him, he decided to replace it with a new, mechanical one. Well, the Lord Admiral's instructions were clear. She was supposed to find his other daughter. This will of course take time, but for now it's quite a lot. Recent events in the castle have made her work much easier. Now no one will have time to stand in her way. Now she

just needs to find the little kitten... And deliver it safe and sound to Antares ... The latter didn't make her happy, not to mention the fact that it wouldn't be easy... She touched the mask on her face. Sometimes you have to accept that you don't have everything. Fortunately, with any luck she will be able to talk to her sister. She removed the blades from her fingers. Yes, this will be a fascinating and very fun discussion. She giggled as she thought about finally getting her revenge on her traitorous sister.

She looked at the others. Grag also replaced his limb with a cybernetic prosthetic and looked determined. He didn't want to get hit by stupid kids or underrated clones again. She may have to keep an eye on him so that he doesn't take out his anger on the cat's companions. On the other hand, no one cared about that stupid clone, Grag could have turned its head into a mantelpiece or something. In addition to him, she also took with her her Shiren Marksman and a halfling named Mogo , who was a champion in throwing weapons. Her new acquisition was Ghoran Wes, whom she recruited on Taurus. She was a terrorist who fought against Horde Prime's troops using poisons. She was extremely effective and created a real terror among the clones, but shortly after the cocky fool fell, she continued to carry out attacks on those she believed to be his loyalists, even in liberated areas, and was eventually imprisoned after causing many accidental deaths. She was therefore a valuable asset among her mongrels. Although she wasn't sure how much I had to count on her loyalty, for someone with such skills she could afford to take some risks. Unfortunately, the men the Lord Admiral had assigned to her were another matter.. See among them this strange trio called the Star Siblings. They were the first inhabitants of the Ravaged Zone they met, and it was thanks to them that Antares learned about his daughter. That in itself was enough for her to feel contempt for them, but they were also former warriors and idealists, and she truly hated those. Unfortunately, she couldn't get rid of them that easily, apart from the fact that they were soldiers of the Fearless Armada, they were famous among the inhabitants of Etheria , but luckily this stupid Dark sorceress made it very easy for her to solve this problem. If something happens to

them, she will be able to blame everything on her or that aristocrat. Apart from that, there were a lot of people from Atrax , for example Kay, a quite handsome red-haired boy.

However, they all counted for nothing compared to her companion. Lady Sorrowflame Just packed. The mechanical assistant, a terrifying multi-limbed droid, followed her, ready to carve up any corpse she pointed at him. She took a portable workshop with her, but apart from that she didn't have much belongings. She was glad that the ancient Dragon Necromancer would accompany her. She was one of the few people she genuinely liked, her presence was invaluable.

„So where do we go first?" She asked the dragon vampire, and Lady Sorowflame spoke thoughtfully.

„Well, there is one place that I am very interested in, but for now we also have to deal with the Lord Admiral's orders. I suggest that we go near the border of Dryl and the country of scorpions. Queen plan on gathering her forces there anyway, and I'll be a few hours' flight or even less from these ruins. Does this aristocrat seem like a promising ally to you.„ She addressed her in the dwarven language.

„No one is a perfect ally, but I like her. She has a good head on her shoulders and seems to be sincere in what she does... „ she didn't finish because she saw that the queen was walking towards them. She looked bad, and it probably happened to her during that daring escape. She was pale and her hair was ruffled. Her right arm was wrapped in a bandage.

„Catra's father left you here to help us?„ She asked, looking at them skeptically.

„First of all, we are here free your friend's little sister, but overall we're going to help..."

To emphasize hers, she flexed her fingers and extended her claws. Glimmer looked at her new cybernetic hand strangely. True,

itwas wonderful, but the queen probably had something more in mind. Did Shadow Weaver say something about her disagreement with Antares ?

„We'll keep an eye on you”. Glimmer said coldly.

„That's good, because we'll need every eye.„ she said and pointed to her only visible eye.

Chapter End Notes

I have a slight cold, so the next chapter will come maybe a little later.

The absolutely perfect, awesome and unique creature

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She woke up. The first thing she felt was cold. Her whole body was shivering because of the cold that penetrated her. She started breathing heavily. Her throat hurt, like the eyes that were blinded by the bright light. She was bathed in a sea of scents so strong they almost intoxicated her. The air was different than it should have been, different than before, although, she wasn't sure if it had been any before… … She didn't remember anything. She didn't know who she was or where she was. and what will happen to her. All she was really sure was that she was… That she exist. It was a feeling both wonderful and terrifying. She was someone... But it's hard to figure out who. She knew certain things, such as that she had to close her eyes because there was light shining into them, probably from lamps, which could damage them. She understood that you were cold because she was naked. She also understood that she should avoid this state of affairs, not only because of the cold, although she didn't quite understand why. It didn't matter anyway because those people around her told her to get up. When she did not respond to their commands, they forced her to stand. Then she heard a voice, hard and metallic, but not devoid of emotion. She recognized that there was pride in it, although she did not understand what its owner could be pleased with.

"Indeed, an absolutely perfect, amazing and unique creature. Much better than the others. Check her out and take her to her bed, let her rest."

She looked up and saw a huge metal figure with four legs spread wide apar. tAt first she thought it was a Droid, but after a while

she came to the conclusion that it was probably something else, because it was too human... The names of mechanical intelligent races appeared in her memory, although she knew well that she had never met any of them. She realized that there was a lot of knowledge in her head, the origin of which she did not know. She didn't have time to think, because people dressed in white pushed her and took her to one room. There, various things were done to her, for example, things were put into the body, her ears and mouth were looked into, she was weighed, measured, and scanned. At one point, a man stuck a sharp needle into her body. She screamed and hit him with her claws. She cut the flesh, blood splattered… The man screamed, but the others started laughing. During the next punctures, she was held tighter, although she struggled and tried to break free. No one paid attention to her screams and hissing. Finally it was over and they gave her a shirt and pants and took her to bed. She was very tired, but she had no idea why, so she lay down in bed and fell asleep.

As soon as she closed her eyes, she saw chaotic and incomprehensible images. So she got up from the bed and started looking around. She was in a large empty room with a few beds. She couldn't get a good look at them because they were covered with screens, but there were at least three of them in total. Two people were standing at the door. They seemed dangerous and ready to harm anyone who annoyed them. She covered herself with the blanket and continued to look around, not sure what she was going to do. She was then approached by a woman who was waiting at a table in the corner of the room. She liked her appearance. She had burgundy hair, cropped short and a round face. You smiled at her and asked.

„What can I do for you? Do you want something to eat or can I take you to the toilet?”

When the woman mentioned food she felt hungry and also thirsty, but she had questions for the woman.

„I… I see things…. „ she asked uncertainly.

„ Do you see things? Can you explain?„ replied the woman with concern in her voice.

„Yes. I just close my eyes but they appear. I don't want to see them!„ She explained feeling angry. Her claws slipped from her fingers.

„Oh, they're just dreams. Everyone has them. Don't be afraid of them. They can be beautiful... You'll see for yourself someday! „ The woman said, smiling at her. She felt like she breathed a sigh of relief. She nodded when she heard this answer .

„Dreams... I know about them, although I don't know how I know about them. Now I'd like to eat something... Then you could take me to the toilet.” She said in a sleepy voice

The woman smiled again and left. Soon she got in with a man carrying a tray with food on it. There were a few pieces of meat, milk with some cereal, some fruit, hard-boiled and soft-boiled eggs, and some vegetables. The smells made her instantly perk up. Her stomach began to growl and saliva filled her mouth.

„Take whatever you want. Go ahead, feel free.„ Said the woman and handed her a plate. Almost without a second thought, she took all the meat and eggs. She ate quickly, as if someone would take the food away from her at any moment... Perhaps that would have happened if she ate too slowly, but in a few minutes she devoured everything on the plate. Then she went to the toilet, constantly watched by guards, and when she returned, she felt sleepy again. She quickly fell asleep and slept for a long time, this time not bothered by dreams.

She woke up with a start when something climbed onto her bed. She jumped to her feet and saw a humanoid creature, like a human-cat hybrid. Her tail bristled and she stretched out her claws and bared her teeth. The second creature looked at her in surprise and turned its head as it approached and began to smell her. She continued to hiss, but she wasn't aggressive, she even seemed friendly.

„Who are you?„ she asked after a while.

„ I'm my… myself. „ She answered him uncertainly, because she just realized that she didn't know who she was. It was frustrating and disturbing at the same time.

„Hello Mayself, nice to meet you!„ she said and started rubbing against her. She squealed softly and the thing moved back and she cringed.

„There are three of us.„ Said the person. that she hadn't seen. She craned her neck and saw the second feline creature. It was finer and slimmer than the first one. It had a calm, slightly amused face with golden eyes, and this first creature had one green eye and the other golden. Carefully, because she wasn't sure if she was allowed to do this, she got up from the bed and approached the third creature, wagging her tail uncertainly. The third one was smiling all the time, although she had the impression that this smile was somehow strange.

„Are you telling US? Why are you telling US?„ She asked confused.

„You are quite stupid too... All three of us are similar. You are the same creature as me. Only I'm smarter and you two are stupid. But maybe it's good, so be it. In siblings there must always be one smart one, one stupid one and one mediocre one.„ She said and touched her face with her fingers. Then one of the guards came up and called out.

„To bed! Don't get too familiar!”

All three of them went back to bed, although the second one looked sad and the third one looked at the guard so strangely that he flinched.

After some time, they were woken up and taken away for further tests. She decided to call the other two Cuddles and Smilies... Smilies calmly underwent all the procedures, although she was constantly looking at the doctors with scowls. Cuddles broke out, cried and hissed a little. She understood her and also became

aggressive when they pricked her and did similar painful things. Then they were taken to another place where they could exercise. There were many types of weapons there, as well as a very high climbing wall and a swimming pool. She liked it here and played almost carelessly for a while, although out of the corner of her eye she saw several people writing down what they were doing. She didn't care about it, she just took some weapon and started hitting the mannequin with it, while Cuddles climbed the wall and Smiles was looking at the knives. Then they gathered her in the common dining room, where there were many more people. She was surprised to find that they looked a lot like the woman they met at the very beginning. They only had multi-colored hair. Burgundy. blue, sometimes pink... They were shown where the food was so they took it and then they were shown which table they should sit at. She was very hungry again, so she ate with gusto. Some women looked on, uncertain and surprised. She didn't really like the look some of them were giving them. They seemed scared, maybe surprised, she wasn’t sure.

After the meal, they were taken to the bathroom. They could take a bath in the large bathtub. That was the first time she could see herself in the mirror. She was indeed very similar to the other two. Cuddles hissed a little at its reflection and then laughed, Smiles didn't pay much attention to the reflection. The next cycle, because she wasn't sure if she could call it a day or how she knew what a day was, was similar, although this time they were accompanied by several people. One of them was looking at Smiles very carefully. Suddenly she grabbed her and the cat girl stabbed him with a knife. Blood flowed again, and Smiles watched the screaming guy until the knife was taken from her.

She noticed that after this incident, the people with them began to look at them more carefully than before, but she didn't care about it, she just started playing with Cuddles. After a while, they started rolling on the ground and wrestling. They laughed out loud and were so happy that they started purring while hugging each other.

Immediately after waking up again, she sensed that something had changed. The woman who visited them was clearly upset, even sad. As if she was afraid of something. Smiles also felt it, she put her ears back and waited with her claws outstretched, as if someone could attack her at any moment. Only Cuddles didn't care about anything. Finally, a large group of guards came and started leading them away. When one of them grabbed her, she started struggling, scratching and biting. One of the guards screamed as she bit his finger off. Cuddles hid under the bed and they had to drag it out by force. The girl cried as they held her. She realized that it was the first time in your life that you had seen someone cry. Only Smiles seemed calm, as if she didn't care. She allowed herself to be taken out and did not put up any resistance. They walked down the hall and then into the elevator. The place they were in was huge, she didn't even know what it was called. Has it always been here? Did anything else exist in the world? Yes, names like forest, desert or mountains appeared in her mind. They certainly weren't in any of those places.

They stood in front of a door, wide and double-leaf. She felt fear. She knew that something terrible was waiting behind this door... Smiles also guessed it. As soon as they stopped, she grabbed the guard holding her wrist and cut his veins with her claws before running away. However, everyone was prepared for this, because as soon as she started running, several electric bolts were fired at her. Two hit her, but even though she fell to the floor, Nada tried to crawl.

„This one will go later. Now take the third one, it's the most promising anyway.” said the officer-looking guard. She was grabbed tightly by the arms and dragged out the door. She found herself in an oval and bright room with an armchair in the middle. The entire room smelled of fear and pain. Despite her resistance, they strapped her down. Strong and precise. She couldn't move. Even her head was immobilized and her eyelids were lifted up with pieces of adhesive tape. She hissed and growled, but they ignored her. Finally, they put a strange camera in her face. She wasn't sure why, but he scared her. Two people who looked like

doctors were tinkering with it. Finally one of them shouted that everything was ready and they moved away.

She felt it. Thoughts, feelings that weren't hers, that were forced into her head. Knowledge she didn't want, terrifying knowledge. She understood more and more, knew more and more with each breath, but her mind rejected it like her body rejected disease. She saw images of war, suffering and cruelty. She also learned how to hurt others. How to make them suffer or die, quickly or slowly. She learned the secrets of most species, but not to save anyone, but to kill better. She already understood how the weapons they had been given during training worked. She gained memories whose context she did not understand. They concerned war, fighting, and terrible things. She screamed and asked them to stop, but they continued. She couldn't even lose consciousness. It felt like it was going on forever. It seemed to her that she had spent an eternity in that chair, longer than her whole life. When it was all over, she heard people around her talking with great satisfaction, but she didn't have the strength to even move. All she could smell was the stench of her own sweat and urine, she must have peed herself during all this... As they unbuckled her from the seat, she sank into the darkness.

The dreams have come... They weren't beautiful as she was promised. Instead, they were full of suffering, pain and war. She dreamed of war and fighting, although until recently she only knew the place where she was imprisoned. Because it was a prison... She heard screams and gunshots, smelled blood and hot metal. She felt pain and fear that she couldn't escape from.

She finally woke up in a bed, not even her own, but the one where Cuddles had slept earlier. The other two girls were also here... Cuddles was sitting on the bed, hugging her knees, and Smiles was clenching and unclenching her hands. It seemed to be in slightly better condition than the others.

„Smiles, what did they do to us?„ she asked, hugging her arms. Her clothes were changed when she was brought here.

„Smiles? Is that what you called me? Well, it's always a name. „ said the third girl and laughed briefly. „It was conditional training, but you should know it yourself, because you have the same knowledge as me. Although I had already been conditioned earlier. Before we became conscious. That's probably why I'm so smart.„ she explained and smiled wider.

„What will they do with us now?„ she asked, wanting to control the shivers that were shaking her body.

„What we were created for... They will forge us into weapons.„ said Smiles and laughed.

In the following days, training began. Their weapon skills, physical fitness and even problem-solving skills were tested. Tests and training lasted many hours, so each evening they were so exhausted that they fell asleep immediately. But the dreams still came back, as scary as before. She didn't know if day or night was worse. They were also examined from time to time, although not as intensively as before. They continued to eat meals together with these women. Now she realized that they were clones, although she had no idea whose clones they were. It probably wasn't important to them, they weren't clones of those women. They were fed twice a day, once before training they were given a lighter meal, and in the evening, after a long day of work, they were given enough food to fill them up. They ate slightly better than the clones, they were given meat, cream and yak, as well as a strange paste that probably contained vitamins, everyone made sure they ate it. They also took a shower every day, quick and warm, it was probably the most pleasant moment of the whole day. They didn't have their own things, they were given normal clothes, but they were changed every day.

Cuddles was the most physically fit of them, and during wrestling matches she always won, effortlessly overpowering them, even when both of them stood up to her. She also seemed to understand the instructors' instructions even before they said

them to you. As if she could sense their thoughts. However, she was the most sensitive . Of the three of them, she was the only one who cried, and she cried every night. She wasn't the brightest either and didn't understand all the instructors' instructions. That's why they tried to protect her. However, it was not easy, because every day more and more was expected of them, and the penalties for failure were severe. They were punished mainly by electrocuting them, but sometimes they were also simply beaten, taking care not to permanently damage them.

Smiles was obedient, but she was still watched most carefully of all of them. She had the impression all the time. that the third of her sisters is up to something. Without a doubt, she was the smartest of them all. But there was something strange about her. She was more focused and composed, but also dangerous and scary. She was nice to Cuddles, but she looked at her differently, as if suspicious and distrustful, and a bit as if she was jealous... But the main enemy were the instructors, and the only person who showed some heart was the caretaker-clone. One day, probably the sixtieth , they again sensed j that something is wrong. The woman who took care of them came in worried and said that today was an important day. Her voice was cracking, she could smell her fear. Are they trying to put something terrible in their heads again? However, even as she was being conditioned, the clone woman didn't seem that worried.

„Today is an important day. Your biggest test. Even our father will be there. So you must be brave... You must be strong… I know it will be difficult, but you must do your best... and do what they tell you.”

They were led to another room, where there were Three black doors. Each of them was taken behind a different door and slammed shut. There was a laser gun on the table and a door in front of it. There was an automatic energy rifle on the ceiling that was pointing at her. Then a man was pushed through the door. A voice came from hidden speakers, the same voice she had heard the first day.

„He opposed us, so he was sentenced to death. Kill him or die yourself, choose.„ He ordered sharply.

She looked around terrified, not knowing what to do. The man cried and begged for mercy. But the voice kept telling her to kill him. He demanded it louder and louder and more violently. She couldn't oppose him... But she didn't want to hurt that man... He hadn't done anything, he wasn't her enemy. But the voice was persistent. The rifle took aim.

„Kill or be killed.„ He ordered and fired next to her. She grabbed the gun, but still did nothing. She couldn't just kill him. She could not !.

„KILL OR BE KILLED!„ this time the voice screamed. The rifle fired and hit right next to her. So she took the gun in both hands and aimed it at the bound man... Her hands were trembling. the man was crying and she was aiming at him. She fired. The man fell dead. She moved to her knees. Two guards came inside and dragged her outside. Smiles was already waiting there. She seemed unfazed, as if nothing had happened... One of them was taken out of the room, Cuddles was nowhere to be found, they didn't ask what happened to her , they knew full well what fate must have befallen her. Their caretaker wasn't there either, but that was what everyone was wondering. They lost their sister, the weakest one, the one they wanted to take care of... After a few minutes, Smiles started staring at her. She did this for a long time, for an hour or two... She finally spoke.

„It is your fault! You know very well that only one of us can stay! They don't need more like us! And they wanted you from the beginning! That one was weak And I... I'm too smart! I will not obey their orders! Now they'll get rid of me! Unless... „ And she jumped at her with her claws. She threw it off the bed and onto the floor. They started struggling. The smiley wanted to reach her throat. She pushed it away with a Strong Leg Strike, but it jumped at her again. This time, however, she was prepared. She caught it in the air and spun it around, pressing it to the floor. She dug her knees into her stomach. She grabbed her by the neck, but the

Smiles bit her hand until blood flowed. She didn't even scream. She didn't know what she wanted to do. The reflexes she felt told her to kill the other girl, but ... She didn't want to do it... However, she knew that if she just loosened her grip, the other girl would attack her. She extended the claws of one hand and struck the other hand in the face. Smiles screamed and grabbed her eye. Then the guards burst into the room. They shocked her with electric batons. She lost consciousness... When she woke up, she was alone...

All subsequent days became similar to the previous ones... Unbearably similar. She would get up, trained, eat her evening meal, go to sleep and it would all start over again. What changed most was that she was now alone. There was no one in the room, she had no one to talk to. Sometimes it happened that she didn't say a single word for whole days, apart from answering the instructors' questions. But something has changed here too. In addition to instructors, she now had teachers. They introduced themselves to her... They tried to talk to her. They smiled. Some even tried to be nice. They were involved in teaching her things that required greater Commitment. Unlike the uniformed instructors, they did not try to hide their identity from her. While the instructors tried to make her focus primarily on the task and not ask unnecessary questions, the teachers encouraged her to participate in the lessons. They wanted her to understand as much as possible of what they were teaching her. Besides, they didn't beat her, and usually they didn't even raise their voices. In fact, they looked more scared than she was. Some even looked like they didn't want to be here. She understood them. She would rather be somewhere else, although she had no idea where else was. However, she liked these lessons, they were something nice during the day. She could rest during them. To calm down. They taught her things like philosophy, galactic politics, biology, and even etiquette, although she didn't fully understand the latter
What she liked most was when they taught her strategy and command. Then they played games with her or presented problems to solve. Then she could forget a little about how terrible her life was. The knowledge that was pressed into her

head allowed her to understand that what was happening here was not normal. It is not something that should happen or be done to another person. There was a certain cruelty in it, because she was aware of the abnormality of what was happening around her. It made her hate this existence more than if she thought it happened to everyone. That's why she rebelled more and more often and bit instructors. Initially, she wasn't even punished for this, much less than for simple incorrectly followed orders. This only frustrated her more. So she tried to use weapons against him, since they wanted her to know how to use them, they could hide her compartment. Here they were more aggressive, overpowering them quickly and painfully. However, they were careful not to seriously harm her. As soon as she calmed down, they let her go. But all this only fueled her fury. Actually, she wanted them to do something to her... To finally end it. So that they would do with her the same thing they did with Smiles and Cuddles. One day, the same doctor who had been with her when she was conditioned passed by. She guessed he didn't think she would remember her. When he got close, she jumped at him and dug her claws into his eyes. The second blow tore her throat, but then they dragged her away. She was taken to an empty room, where she waited tied up for an hour. A man in the appearance of a droid also came to her, she heard his name was Jantar. He looked at her for a long time until he finally said.

„In your case, some disobedience can be tolerated. Dr. Kac, however, was a very valuable specialist... It will be difficult to replace him. Why you need to learn to take responsibility for your actions. Follow me though... „ He said and they took her to the top of the Tower... She spent the whole night there... It was also the first night when she saw the world outside the Citadel... She survived despite the terror and hundreds of birds just waiting to tear her alive...

However, something began to change. There was a kind of nervous atmosphere. Everyone looked scared. She saw it best by watching the clones in the dinning. She had excellent hearing, and

women didn't try to speak quietly anyway. They whispered something about a big attack. About the battle that is coming and that they may have to run away... About the Swarm that will soon come and consume Atrax . She was curious about it. She had knowledge about the Swarm in her head and knew that it was extremely dangerous. It can even swallow entire planets. If it comes here too, will time destroy the citadel. She would like it to be like this Gaining some courage, she asked the teachers about the situation. Some were reluctant, but most were also worried about the Swarm, and eventually some told her that the Swarm had attacked nearby Kesler, so they feared it would come here too.

And then One day, no one came to training for her. So she sat alone in her bed, waiting for… She had no idea what. When she didn't get anything to eat all day, she was probably at the door and she started to listen. She heard screams and gunshots. She wasn't sure if the Swarm had already arrived or if something else had happened. In any case, she was happy that something would change, because for her every change was a change for the better. Finally, a clone woman, dressed much more casually than the ones she had seen before, came into her room and brought her a whole bucket of some kind of fried breaded bird. She seemed very cheerful.

„I'm sorry you had to wait so long, but today is a big day. Jantar is dead! We are all free!„ She cried, tears streaming down her face.

„So I can leave here and go somewhere, right?” she asked skeptically. As she expected, the woman was confused and handed her the cup.

„Take this and eat your fill. Everything will be fine now.” she said and wanted to pet her, but she changed her mind when she saw her look and left.

It wasn't, although she had to admit it was better, at least at first. Female Clones had now replaced most of the guards, and those who weren't clones were new anyway. They were nicer, they didn't shout at her, in fact they were a little afraid of her. She liked it. Who was afraid of her, couldn't hurt her. And they were afraid of her, which means that she was dangerous and that she was able to defend herself. Because these workouts made her stronger. They showed her how to hurt others, and that started her being able to ambush those who wanted to hurt her. So often, when she was standing in front of a door waiting to be able to enter it, because everything wasn't ready yet, she would stare at the guards until they started sweating. In fact, everyone started looking at her the same way they used to look at Smiles. Whenever she remembered her sister, she rejected the thought. She didn't want to remember her , and she didn't want to remember Cuddles. They disappeared because of her. If it weren't for her, if she weren't so perfect... They would be the ones with her. And now she was alone and would be alone. She had to come to terms with it, because what else could she do?

However, training has not changed. The instructors still expected her to do her best, but at least they didn't beat her, at least if one of the clone women was around. However, she herself tried to meet their requirements. She had to become better and stronger, so that when the opportunity to escape came, she would leave this place once and for all!

But then she appeared. She was a female clone, but everyone was afraid of her, especially those who weren't clones. She saw her for the first time during one of the training sessions. She was dressed in a silver-blue vest and on her head a delicate white diadem with sapphires. She entered the training room and stood with her arms crossed over her chest, smiling mockingly. Something about that smile reminded her of Smiles, but there was much more mockery in it. She looked at her for a moment, and then the woman giggled and walked over to her.

„I am the Supreme Queen Ka.„ She said and without warning she punched her in the face. She was so surprised that she didn't

even try to dodge. She staggered back and almost fell, then felt a surge of rage in her heart and lunged at the woman. However, she put an electric baton in front of her and shocked her. She found herself on the floor again, and the pain paralyzed her body.

„Now that we've introduced ourselves, you can get back to training.„ she said and retreated to the wall, but did not stop watching her. She slowly stood up and went back to training, trying to ignore the clone woman. During this training, Queen Ka no longer spoke to her. She didn't see her again that day either. However, the next day, while she was training in jumping and acrobatics, the Queen Ka was present. Being watched by This woman distracted her and she slipped and fell painfully. Before she got up, she felt a strong impact at work, knocking her to the ground again. A shoe pressed her to the floor.

„And this is supposed to be this wonderful creature that our father devoted so much time and resources to creating and training? Pathetic!„ she said, leaning her ear to it. She smelled of strong perfume, alcohol and some kind of drugs. Then she let her get up and looked at the exercises again. It was like this for the next few days. The Supreme Queen of Ka sometimes observed her training, and sometimes personally punished her for her failures, usually in such a way that she could not give her back.

But eventually something changed. On three hundred sixty day, which was different from all the previous ones. She sensed the tension and anger among the remaining female clowns. She was taken to this room she had never seen before. There was a dressing room and a man, an Android, handed her clothes and told her that she should choose something from them. She donned baggy pants and a long-sleeved vest. She would have worn more clothes but he wouldn't let her. Then she was taken to the living room. There, Queen Ka was waiting for her in an armchair, drinking wine. When she saw her, she went to her and said.

„There always comes a moment when little kitten has to go to a new owner.„ she said and giggled. And the eyes were full of

contempt and malice. This woman hated her, even though she hadn't done anything to her. She felt the rage again , which burned with cold fire in her heart. With a lightning-fast movement, she struck the woman with her hand with outstretched claws. She felt resistance as she cut through muscle and bone. Blood splattered on her and her new clothes. Ka let out a short scream and jumped away from her, and then some guards grabbed her and pressed her to the ground. The Queen ordered her to be put on her knees and to raise her head so that she could look into her face. Her right side turned into a bloody mess, but the woman didn't stop smiling.

„When little kittens scratch, their claws need to be Cut of.„ She laughed and told the doctors to take him in. She tried to pull herself free, but those security guards knew how to hold someone down so they wouldn't move. After a while, the doctors arrived and at first they approached their employer, but she waved her hand and said.

„Deal with me later. First you need to remove the claws of this creature?„ she pointed at it.

„Then we need to take her to the infirmary, because it is a painful procedure.„ Said the Elven doctor, But Queen Ka shook her head.

„NO. You will do it here and now! Without anesthesia.”

„But it's barbaric.„ Said the doctor, but Queen Ka pulled out a short Knife and moved it to her face so that blood flowed.

„One more word and I'll gouge out your eyes and make you eat them. „ She drawled indistinctly, the doctor swallowed loudly. The guards straightened her left arm, and then the doctors started working. They pulled out their scalpels and started removing her claws. They didn't look at her, their hands were shaking. She felt terrible pain where it cut her body. When they finally finished mutilating her hand, they bandaged it and only then did they deal with their employer. They took her to another room, where she sat crouched for some time, clutching her injured hand. She cried

in silence, alone, with no one to help her. Soon she was taken to a large garage and put into a vehicle. It was the first time she left the citadel. The windows were tinted so she couldn't see the world outside, but she still felt a strange mix of fear and excitement, despite the pain in her hand. She came to a large building that looked like a palace. There she went to the living room and waited for some time. It felt like hours were passing by. Maybe it was, she wasn't sure. Suddenly she heard screams and gunshots. She crouched in the corner of the room and extended her claws, ready to finally Fight for herself. Finally, a tall Pahtra entered , his body covered with scars and a he nasty expression on his face. When he approached her, she tried to hit him with her claws and hissed at him. He jumped away from her and looked at her curiously.. He finally said.

„You're coming with me, young one.„ he said in a hoarse voice.

„Why would I do that!„ She screamed, ready to fight, because she was fed up with everything. She wasn't afraid to die, just to end it all.

„First of all, I'm your uncle. Secondly, only I can give you freedom. Third, I just killed Queen Ka.„ He said and laughed darkly too. She thought about what he said for a moment before finally following him. Nothing that awaited her could be worse than what had already happened.

Chapter End Notes

Another grim chapter. What do you think of the other Catgirls?

Failures

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

He was driving one of those anti-gravity vehicles that he designed himself so long ago... He hadn't sat at the controls of any of them for many years, but he hadn't forgotten how to drive them. He was born, or rather created, with the ability to drive a multitude of machines, ground , space and even submarines. However, he had to learn to manage it himself, although it was not particularly difficult. He created them so that anyone could learn to fly them. They were supposed to be easy to drive and at the same time durable and easy to maintain. In a word, they were supposed to be the pillar of his empire... Now, however, they have become the most popular means of transport in all of Etheria . Thanks to them, travel around the entire planet has been revolutionized. He had a right to be proud of that... Unlike many other things he had done to this place. He knew that the guilt would haunt him for the rest of his days, maybe even longer, if what the people of Icarus and Eridani said was true.

However, perhaps thanks to this expedition he will be able to at least a little atone for his sins. He wasn't entirely sure what its purpose was, except that it had something to do with the Magical Ruins that Shadow Weaver was about to search. They were supposed to find a place there so that they could find another place, thanks to which they would be able to find another place where the First Ones were hiding. And there was another sword involved in everything…. Why did everyone like to make powerful weapons look like swords? It was completely ridiculous and absurd. There were so many possibilities, for example you could create a giant droid , a tank or a giant spaceship, something that

is dangerous in itself, instead of enclosing such great power in an oversized knife. He knew that the swords are important for many inhabitants of Etheria, and even the entire galaxy from what he had heard. The inhabitants of Eridani worshiped some warrior woman with a great sword, Entrapta told him that some warrior woman brought by that admiral also proudly carried some strange sword... He didn't understand what it was about, and he didn't want to find it out. Worse still, he hated magic, and now he had to travel with three sorcerers, two of them who had reason to hate him and either his former right-hand or a sorceress whose stupidity and incompetence were astonishing. They were supposed to investigate the ruins of a magical college, but honestly, he didn't understand why his participation in this expedition was needed. He suspected that he was supposed to ensure the safety of the others. There was nothing strange about it, after all, he was a born warrior. After Entrapta's treatment , he physically towered over most of Etheria's inhabitants , and probably many of his brothers as well. After all, he was much more experienced than them and had learned to cope despite his weaknesses and even draw strength from themHis wife created him a new suit of power armor, which he took to the wedding just in case. Only Entrapta didn't see it as strange. They designed it together as you practice the best inventions. It was resistant and made him stronger than any of the Scorpions, and it had many special functions that made him prepared for any conditions, for anything that might come his way. Of course, even in everyday life he needed such armor. The last five years spent on Beast Island, the most dangerous place on the planet, it also made him stronger. He had to protect his wife and then his child. He knew this place better than anyone in all of Etheria ... Almost anyone.

He glanced sideways at the former king consort standing next to him. This man spent twelve years on the Beast Island... Alone, deprived of any support, or even any hope that someone would get him out of there. Nobody even knew he was alive.. Where he was sure where this rumor came from. He never claimed that Mikah died in battle at the hands of his soldiers. Of course, being sent to the Beast Insland, especially at that time, was tantamount

to a death sentence... He never admitted it to himself, but it was the truth. He convinced himself that these were all scientific expeditions aimed at discovering the secrets of the First Ones. He and Shadow Weaver had only been there once and they barely made it out alive. The island wanted to absorb them, devour them... He wondered if what they had done, what people they were then, had made them more susceptible to the cursed signal. However, he could not deny that what he saw there made a huge impression on him Back then, he didn't know what power was hidden in the First Ones' technology, but he suspected that Shadow Weaver understood it perfectly. At first they wanted to send fully equipped research teams there, but when most of them didn't come back, and those who did came back with terrible stories, they stopped wasting men and equipment and started sending prisoners and disobedient citizens there... He could fool himself that all of them they have a chance to survive, but the truth was that he sentenced hundreds of people to death. He never found any bodies. He hoped that the local fauna had eaten the unfortunate people, or rather their corpses. Because the thought of them staying there, consumed by the island, forever trapped in their despair, was unbearable...

And this man survived there despite the fact that he should have given up all hope and succumbed to this terrible desire to give up and become a part of this place" He himself, ironically, was saved by his devotion to Horde Prime. What saved Shadow Weaver had no idea. After all, this woman never believed in any values... Was it her own pride and arrogance that saved her?

„I'm not happy that I have to travel with you either...„ Mikach said with undisguised reluctance in his voice. He sighed and said.

„I don't feel any dislike towards you... I guess this is our first conversation... I don't know you, even when we were enemies during the rebellion, I knew almost nothing about you. „ he drawled in a gloomy voice. The sorcerer looked at him in surprise.

„You weren't interested in who the enemy commanders were?„ he asked in disbelief,

„We clones could barely see our own individuality, let alone our enemies. Besides, Horde Prime didn't think it was important for us to understand things like politics or psychology. Honestly, he didn't fully understand it himself But he didn't have to worry about such things either. He had such power that he did not have to pay attention to any political arrangements. As far as I know, he simply murdered the leaders of the conquered worlds. You know something about it yourself. This almost happened to your daughter too. It was actually Catra who saved her when she came aboard the Velvet Glove. She was the one who stood up for her before Horde Prime . I saw it myself.„ he explained calmly, in a slightly thoughtful voice. The King Consort bowed his head, staring blankly ahead.

„Glimmer told me about it right after the war, but Catra didn't want to dwell on it. Why are you telling me this? I know you don't like her, and it's mutual... „ He could hear the surprise in his voice.

„Because I see no reason to lie or hide the truth. I don't want to flatter you, I don't care what you think about me. Anyway, a few words won't change that. I will forever remain who I was for you. The invader, the One who brought war to your peaceful planet.„ He turned and continued to stare at the road ahead of them. They were on the golden grass plain surrounding the Whispering Forest. It was beautiful here, the moonlight reflected on the waving sea of grass. Beast Island was also beautiful in its own way, but this was something different. At that moment he regretted his imprisonment because he couldn't enjoy such sights, but it was good. After all, this was supposed to be a punishment for what he had done to the inhabitants of this world. So far, His punishment has hardly bothered him . It was much more burdensome for his wife, who was self-imprisoned with him on this cursed island. But now he understood how much he had lost by living a semi-hermit existence.

„And I still think we should teleport there. „ The woman in the back of the vehicle muttered.

„It would be difficult to move the three of us, and besides, I decided that we needed some supplies for a longer journey. We also don't know yet whether Ireanis or Shadow weaver will join us. I gave this strange sorceress Saihe My ring, in which I enchanted a bit of my magic. To be honest, I don't like it very much, but it's the only way they can easily track us down. Besides, even if transport everything magically, I don't know if I would be too exhausted. I haven't done this for many years. Since the war and that battle."

The king consort's sister nodded.

„ I remember, you brought yourself and the Star sisters back then. Halo and Pulsar… Yours were so powerful. But she still beat you... „ Castaspella said, and then she reflected. „ I'm sorry, I shouldn't bring up such dark memories.„ she looked down.

„Nothing happened, sister. I've come to terms with all this a long time ago... It would be easier, of course, if she was still dead... But Angela is alive... My wife. It's hard for me to describe how much I miss her. How I'm happy and at the same time afraid of meeting her."

His sister smiled understandingly.

„That's how I felt when Horde Prime chipped you . I was afraid of how much you had changed, that he would see and I would have to hurt you. Or worse, you'll hurt Glimmer."

Mikah smiled sadly.

„I remembered you , but my memory was distorted. And believe me, I came close to hurting her... Or you."

There was silence. He guessed that the siblings were remembering those difficult times and that they were both wondering how much the former queen had changed. To distract them from their journey and pointless thoughts, he decided to change the subject.

„What do you think about Lord Admiral Castaspella? Out of all of us, you know him best.”

The Head Sorceress hesitated before answering.

„He seemed to be a good person. I must admit that I don't know anything about such matters, but even I was impressed. He was strong, confident, well-mannered but seemed to be honest. The way he treated Catra... He truly treated her like a daughter... I still have a hard time believing he's the monster Shadow Weaver describes him to be. Despite everything, I'm not sure whether she doesn't want to deceive us all again and slander the father of her former ward and at least hurt her in this way.” She clenched her fists angrily, but her brother shook his head.

„Shadow Weaver She never lied without a reason... In fact, she very rarely lied. She always preferred to distort the truth and bend it to her own goals... That was the case with Adora ... Shadow Weaver truly believed that Adora was special and she sincerely loved this uniqueness. Both Adora and Catra told me a lot about their childhood... „ Mikach said and looked at her with accusation in his eyes. He looked down

„I always believed I was a failure, and in fact I was right, just not for the reason I always thought. I am a failure not because I didn't meet Horde Prime's expectations , because no one did, but because of what I did. Because of the lives I have ruined, the suffering I have caused, the tears I have shed. What happened to Adora and Catra , you, your wife and many inhabitants of this world burdens my conscience and I know well that nothing I do will compensate for it. I am a moral failure.”

There was silence again and they rode forward for some time until finally the queen's husband spoke.

„ Don't expect that your words will move me and that I will start looking at you differently than before. You were a dictator and a conqueror. You were happy about it. Don't deny it!„ Mikach He looked at him with contempt.

„I don't except your forgiveness. I know who I am and what I have done. I'll have to live with it. What do you think about the other case she talked about? About the First Ones.

Mikach thought before answering.

„I am a sorcerer and therefore I will always live a little in the past. I have never been so interested in ancient civilization. My wife knew about these matters, start more now. Sometimes I wonder how much and if she was hiding something from everyone. She ruled Brightmoon for five hundred years. Her power was the Moonstone... But I had a war I had to fight on behalf of her and all of us. Back then, no one expected us that the First Ones would be involved in all this. Then I saw what the Heart is capable of... Let's not be delusional. They are still out there somewhere. They wanted to destroy half of the universe once, and it is rather certain that they will do it again. So even though I hate you, I will travel with you, fight by your side, protect you if necessary... It's all to save your loved ones. I hope I can expect the same from you. „ he looked at him expectantly. He nodded and said.

„I have a family and you probably believe me that I love them. So you really have no reason to worry, I will do everything I can to save her, just like you. „ And he steered the vehicle towards the Valley Of Shattered Armor.

Lady Sorrowflame was ready to go. Although she did not have to use this type of machines, she boarded a twin-engine flying vehicle used by the air cavalry. It was fast, had the ability to take off and land vertically, had a load capacity of thirteen tons, was well armed, but the most important thing was that no moonlight reached its interior. Despite all the precautions she had taken, it still caused her discomfort and could prove dangerous in a critical situation. She was pleased with the turn of events. The Lord Admiral allowed her to stay on this planet so that she could continue her research. This place was fascinating. it held so many secrets that the life of an ordinary mortal would not be enough to

discover them all... Fortunately, she was not a mortal being... On the other hand, she suspected that her time was also limited. In the old days, her existential condition would have made it difficult for her to work, but fortunately, technology enabled her to travel, regardless of the time, both day and night, and she didn't have to waste half of her unlife dozing off in a coffin. This place, this Xadia, was interesting in itself. A crossbreeding between a dragon and an elf, for those were the beings known here as Saihe , was not difficult. In some ways, dragons interbreed surprisingly easily with the other species. But creating a stable hybrid was something much more difficult. if, in fact, an entire subspecies of dragon-elves was created there, it would be worth investigating them... she had not had contact with her own species, or rather with her original species, for many years. Being dead obviously separated her from her kin, and she was a bloodsucker, as she was often called by those who wanted to dress long and painfully. She could transform others. which was perfectly proven by a certain clone that was one of her research subjects and that she planned to use to benefit the Lord Admiral's cause, But this type of creature you could never fully develop. She had tried this many times over the course of her incredibly long life, and had never succeeded in creating anything more than a miserable minion who was only capable of doing her bidding. She has tried to transform the Other Dragon several times , but it is very difficult. Most dragons would fight to the death rather than allow themselves to be transformed into such a creature, and even if they did, it was difficult to control, preferring to risk a second death rather than bend their necks to their new master. Its Creator himself found this out many centuries ago. He was destroyed by her, but unfortunately that didn't mean much now, because Dahak had also abandoned her. However, such hybrids could be an interesting alternative... The fact that they were the works of the ancient and powerful civilizations also made them valuable. Although these creatures were not her primary interest, the mysteries of the body had always fascinated her, and by dissecting both living and dead members of this species, you could learn a lot. However, they were not the main reason why she wanted to find this planet. There was a Star Elf Who was older than the destruction of the

First One’s Empire... If he was still alive and if he had not been affected by the Gap, he probably remembered everything that happened. Perhaps he would answer her questions about what happened to the old Golarion ... Why she had to lose her memories and, most importantly, who murdered her God.

They flew for several hours, and Lady Ka, sitting next to her, sat in her seat without even fastening her seat belt. Sometimes she wondered why living beings cared so little about themselves... They didn't respect the short life they were given... She liked this woman and she was very useful, so she got up and fastened her seat belt herself. The Lord Admiral's left better hand didn't even wake up, apparently the painkillers were still working. Then she turned and looked around the deck out of boredom. Her eyes fell on the Antares mirror, one of the four he had. They were extremely valuable, which is why it's even more unfortunate that two of them were lost, or rather they were in the possession of this runaway aristocrat, although she assumed that this state of affairs would not last for long... Sooner or later they will get her, If Anttares' daughter doesn't do it, the two of them will… They will probably do this while taking over the younger feline hybrid. although she was increasingly wondering whether it would be better not to establish at least temporary cooperation with them. Lady Ka was very much in favor of this solution and maybe she will listen to it, she hasn't decided yet.

As she looked at the mirror like that, a thought must have occurred to her. What if it was one of his mirrors? The manuscript states that many mirrors were Created by Aaravos... But she had rejected that thought so far. It was not created by this elf or any other. They were created by the Krellans, another ancient Race, extremely mysterious. Little was known about them, mainly that they were masters of Energy manipulation. Their disappearance was associated with large-scale destruction of large parts of the galaxy, although this was quite common in the case of falling empires. They were like a big tree that, when it fell, pulled others down, but also created space for others to grow. She was one of

the few beings in the galaxy who was able to observe this phenomenon in person. Unfortunately, her memory was taken away, like most beings in the galaxy. Most, but not all, oh no! The inhabitants of this planet were the best proof of this.

She walked over to the mirror and touched it with her fingertips. She felt them sticking slightly, as if something was sucking them in. She had the impression that all she had to do was press her fingers harder and they would penetrate to the other side. The silvery surface radiated coolness. It wasn't too painful for her , after all, her body itself was as cold as, well, a corpse's. Living creatures, however, must have felt it much more intensely, as if they were touching ice pulled out from the very heart of winter... They used this mirror to communicate over long distances without the risk of being overheard... But it is unlikely that this was its main use, or at least its only use. This item also held secrets. She had been examining it for many years but had not discovered its secrets. For decades it has been unsuccessful in this field... But now she realized that she had found a clue... She had heard rumors and stories about Etharia... About the First Ones constructed the Heart of Etheria here… which absorbed the magic permeating the planet to power an incredibly powerful weapon... Capable of destroying worlds. What almost no one here knew was the fact that Etheria had the Second Starstone. Absalom Station drew its energy using only a fraction of the artifact's power. It also allowed them to navigate through space , thus uniting the galaxy... The First One’s, however, simply used it as a weapon, which did not reflect well on them... but now she saw the similarity in the operation of the mirror and the heart... Could it be that the colonizers of Etheria had once cooperated with the Krellans... Which was an interesting thought, one of many that were running through her head. She felt like there was some secret hiding at the edge of her vision. She felt that all she had to do was look around a little better and discover it. For someone as Old as she was, it was an extremely irritating experience. She needs to find out more about this. This, however, took time, and she had to divide her time between her research and the attempt to free the Lord Admiral's Daughter. Unfortunately, she was the

only person on her expedition sufficiently knowledgeable on this matter. It was frustrating, but where could she get support? Then her eyes fell on the mirror and an idea occurred to her... She smiled, baring her long black fangs.

„It was all a complete failure.” Glimmer said in an exhausted voice. She hadn't seen her this tired since the end of the war. She herself felt great. And that was what scared her the most. She shouldn't feel this good. She came close to death twice, but she was fresh and rested. She was just terribly cold, but she had been cold more than once in this life. After all, she was an Ice Princess, Frosta from the Kingdom of Snow. This was nothing new to her... Except that there was no way she could keep warm. She didn't talk to anyone about it yet, she didn't want to worry the others even more. She just took a sweater, one of those that Aunt Casta made for her, and as if nothing had happened, she drank tea with butter.

„What losses did we actually suffer?„ Mermiasta asked . Seahawk arrived as soon as he heard that there was a fight going on in the castle, but he didn't have time to take part in it. Now he stood by his wife as if he was afraid that she would be the target of the next attack.

“Fifteen guards, including Brother Blade.„ Said the general Juliet in a gloomy tone. Glimmer sucked in a sharp breath.

„We haven't lost that many since the war.„ She said with horror in her voice.

"We haven't lost anyone since the war , but the Brightmoon guard has lost more than twenty members in the last two days. I had never suffered such heavy losses, certainly not since the battle in the Valley of Shattered Armor.„ Said the general in a hard voice. She saw that the woman was furious and hungry for revenge.

„We will deal with recruitment later. Regular troops will suffice. We can hire temporary guards to guard the castle. Many people from Icarus came to the wedding and some of them have military experience.„ Catra said, crossing her arms over her chest.

„This is not the time for us to hire mercenaries, certainly not for such an important and prestigious formation.„ General Juliet growled. Catra scowled at her.

„I know you take it personally, but believe me, we take it that way tooI helped train most of those who died, so I feel responsible for that too„ said the Great Marshal, trying to sound calm. The Saihe woman snorted.

„Everyone knows how you treated your subordinates when you were Hordak's right hand! This is why this rebellion broke out."

Catra bristled at the accusations. She knew her friend wasn't proud of what she did when she served in the Horde.

„Listen, it's time for you all to accuse each other." Mermista said in a tired voice. „ If you want to find the culprits, they are the Aristocrat and that terrible woman. „ she looked at the others, who also calmed down a bit.

„This doesn't change much in our plans. And so we were supposed to send troops to Dryl." Catra said.

„But we don't know if they're really there.„ Mermista said carefully , but Glimmer added.

„But we have no other leads, and anyway, first of all, we have to free the empress. Her Kidnapping was the greatest success of The Comrade General. Shadow Weaver and Lady Cala are undoubtedly very dangerous, but once we free the Hostages, she will have more room to maneuver."

„So we should let this woman who hurt my daughter be free! The Woman, who almost killed her! „ General Juliet said through

clenched teeth. Then Scorpia, who had been silent during this entire discussion, spoke up.

„Your daughter stabbed my wife with a blade! She wanted to help her and... She wouldn't have survived if it weren't for Adora... „ the muscular woman spoke with an anger she had never heard from her. However, there were tears of pain in her eyes. She felt very sorry for what happened to the Flower Princess. She didn't understand why that girl did this to her... Perfuma was nice to everyone and hated violence, although she could defend herself when necessary. She hardly knew Klementine, but over the years she had managed to get to know and she like General Juliet. She commanded an army throughout the war and was brave and determined to protect the Queen. For some reason she didn't like Catra, though she didn't understand why. She couldn't believe that the other girl would do something so terrible on her own. It must have been some great and evil magic. She couldn't find any other explanation.

„My daughter is the victim here! How dare you accuse her of anything! „ The general shouted, all red with rage.

„Everything indicates that your daughter helped murder the guards guarding Lady Cala ... She was the last person to visit this... being.„ Glimmer said slowly, rubbing her bandaged arm. She hadn't seen that the queen had been hurt before.

„My daughter would never do something like that! She was mad at me for that. that... well, that I'm trying to arrange my life after the death of the second Mother.„ Saihe woman said in a slightly calmer voice.

„It's even good that people sometimes do very bad things. „ Adora said suddenly, staring sadly ahead. She hadn't said much so far, she was as exhausted as everyone else, even more so than the rest. She heard that she had performed a miracle and resurrected that girl.

The general looked at the Princess Of Power and smiled darkly.

„Yes, you know well that some people do bad things more often than not.”

Adora stood up and Catra perked up.

„You shouldn't say things like that, not right now.” Glimmer said, but the Queen smiled bitterly at her.

„And when will be the right opportunity to tell the truth?! Even if my daughter did something wrong, it was only because she was unaware and manipulated! As you saw, she fell in love with this woman. She was just innocent and naive.”

„But she was the one who brought Lady Cala here ... It was also thanks to her that we trusted her. „ Adora said, looking at the General, and Scorpia added.

„ I can't believe she didn't know who she was. Maybe I'm not the brightest person under the moon, and sometimes I'm thoughtlessly naive... But even I would notice something like that... After all, she invited her to your house...”

„That's true. Lady Cala is not like us. She always looked at everyone from above, from behind with a gentle and inscrutable smile. She came here from afar, and from what I heard she tried to kill some of her companions before she came to your court. From the very beginning she gave the impression of someone suspicious, unnaturally alien. I know it sounds wrong and doesn't fit our ways, but she was too... perfect?”

„And that smell. You didn't feel it I thought it was some strange prejudice and I flaunted it to everyone, but now I understand that if she had been more decisive and more insightful, maybe all this could have been avoided.„ said the feline woman, smiling darkly. The general sighed and said

„So you've already found the culprit, right ? My daughter is still catatonic, she doesn't talk to anyone... But you make her a perpetrator equal to your mother. “ She looked at Adora and Catra and smiled bitterly. „Well, you are heroes now... How easy it is to

forgive your friends' past sins... „ Her gaze fell on Catra . „However, I have not forgotten the war and what some people did during that time.„ then she looked at Glimmer and said slowly, through pursed lips. „So far, I have agreed to everything, even though my heart was against what you did, Queen! I remained silent, even though I knew you were pushing kingdoms into the abyss. You've already given us into the enemy's hands once... And maybe we're still stuck there.” She shot a look at Catra. „You started this meeting by talking about failure. And you were right. This is all a failure! You are a failure, as is your entire rule. In these few years, you have ruined everything that yours has fought for over the decades. It's a good thing she 's dead, because she would cry over the fate of our kingdom. „ said the General in a very calm voice. Glimmer looked like someone had punched her in the face. She knew that she suffered a lot because of what Nightgale had done , and now General Juliet's words ... They hurt as much as a knife stuck in the stomach.

„Juliet ... I am taking away all your titles, privileges and positions. From now on you will be an ordinary citizen of Etheria . „ Glimmer said. The general nodded and walked stiffly out of the meeting room. As the Saihe woman left, the queen hid her face in her hands.

„I hate all this more and more...” she said and her husband hugged her

Chapter End Notes

This isn't my favorite chapter, but it moved the plot forward.

Alliances

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Lonnie watched the Shadows of Tarak from her castle walls and felt that this was not what she wanted when she brought the rebellion into existence. She didn't want to bring here alien mercenaries from distant parts of the Galaxy... She didn't want to command someone for whom war is the meaning of existence. They fought for freedom, or actually they didn't even fight until recently. Yes, they were a thorn in Glimmer's side, they were a nuisance to her, but they weren't really hurting anyone... Until recently. Kyle was right. They could have reached an agreement with the queen, Entrapta didn't care about her castle anyway, and the inhabitants of Dryl gave power over this place. During the last mission she realized that the other inhabitants of Etheria, let alone the galaxy, did not care about her fighting. She was a pawn, someone who stuck her neck out for others to realize their true intentions... And that didn't just apply to her allies on the planet. For someone like the Lord Admiral, she was just a minor annoyance that he didn't even have to deal with personally. But now it had become more than just a nuisance She kidnapped the empress, perhaps permanently squandering the opportunity to form an alliance of Etheri and the planets once occupied by the Horde. Glimmer now will have to take appropriate action against them... She must free the Empress. Not only because law forbade kidnapping people, but also because she will completely lose her authority. Ironically, she got what she always wanted. She undermined the princesses' right to rule over Etheria . Except she did it at the worst possible time. The Lord Admiral and the Others will use her actions for their own purposes. Now it will be more difficult for Glimmer to resist the influence of extraplanetary forces when she cannot cope with the rebellion on his own planet. Even though she fought so hard for Etheria's independence, she herself

pushed her into the hands of foreign forces. Besides, who were her allies if not foreigners or opportunists. They all, the Chancellor, Midnight Mask and even Halo did not care about the well-being of the inhabitants of her planet, only about their own interests. The Mi-Go terrified even someone raised in the barracks of Fright Zone, and the Shadows of Tarak only really served the sister of women she hated so much. On the other hand, did she really have a reason to hate Catra? She touched the scar on her face. It's true, Hordak's former right-hand girl brought out the worst in them, but it was the same thing she did to herself. But she knew when to choose the better path. During the occupation, they hid in the Wastes, while she faced the invader. She may have done it, at least partly, for selfish reasons. but she still risked her life in the fight against the occupier. She wondered why she really hated her so much. I think it started when Catra attacked her while she was talking to Adora. Now she understood that it was because of jealousy. before, she had only seen it as the cat girl's malice. Perhaps they would have been able to come to an agreement before, but now…

She looked at the courtyard where the Shadows were inspecting their equipment, tidying up the camp, and going about their business. They seemed menacing, but also equally surprised. They did not expect that they would fight together with former cadets who had been trained to fight since childhood. Whatever you say about Shadow Weaver and Hordak, they have given them enough training to make an impact on these veterans. She didn't say what Itel told them, probably almost nothing, apart from sending the invitation. She wasn't sure what they expected. She had the impression that they expected some Forgotten planet inhabited by pink creatures who don't know what fighting is, or a wild place where barbarians with clubs live and the sight of a flashlight makes them fall to their knees. They even took reflective key chains for trade. Now he sees a few boxes standing somewhere on the side, completely useless… Perhaps if they handed them out to children, a few of them would smile, but not before they would run away screaming when they saw the Shadows coming towards them. Hell, she would attack them

herself if she suddenly saw them coming towards her from among the bushes, not knowing whose side they were on. Most were older than them, often covered in scars, with body parts replaced by cybernetic prosthetics. She had seen such inventions in the Crimson Wastes, usually brought by prosthetists from Icarus, but not in this quantity. She had the impression that many of them had deprived themselves of healthy body parts to replace them with implants. Were they willing to sacrifice so much to become better soldiers? They had been fighting for several dozen years for the cause that warmed their hearts. From what she understood, many didn't even remember the war their commander and Lord Admiral had fought in... Such Fierceness terrified her, not only because fighting for so long would have taken a soul out, but also because she feared that she herself was on the best path. to become like them. Currently. as she looked from the walls at both groups looking at each other warily, she realized that for the first time in years she was beginning to think about peace. She finally realized that this War couldn't last forever. That she had to make peace, and not only because, in fact, she couldn't win against the inhabitants of the entire planet, but also because she couldn't let the same thing happen to her people as to these mercenaries. She couldn't let the war become their reason for existence. She did n't want them to become like those soldiers. After all, that's why they deserted from the Fright Zone... To escape from war and fighting. So why did she drag them into another fight? Now she remembered captain Bina words about how she simply couldn't live any other way. She still tried to live the way she had been taught, even though she could have chosen any path. Was she too afraid of change? She didn't know how to answer that. The biggest problem was that she couldn't back out so easily now. They would get along with Glimmer and Catra somehow, they didn't really want this war either, they would probably agree to some kind of settlement. But not their allies from outside the empire… Nor her allies from Etheri. Not to mention the Shadows, whose leader swore war on the Lord Admiral and continued to wage war for over thirty years. She even wondered if the other cat girl didn't drag her into a fight with her uncle as punishment for what happened during the wedding. Although no, Eti wasn't

calculating or cunning. In fact, she seemed like one of the most sincere people she had ever met. In this she was very reminiscent of Entrapta or Scorpia. She spoke the truth, or what she believed to be the truth, even if it might get her in trouble, hurt someone, or make no sense. But regardless of her doubts, she had to do something about it all. So she sighed and went downstairs. Her own people saluted her, But the Shadows only nodded in greeting. It was still more than what she had hoped for. But it was some sign of respect, even minimal. Some of her subordinates were already starting to approach the new guests in Crypto's castle . The tall cat persons were the friendliest, much nicer than their commander, who belonged to the same people. There were also ordinary humans like her, most of whom served as support. The support was usually, but not always, short, hairy creatures with six arms. Their desire to help was tiring, but they all had the kindness and friendly attitude typical of the inhabitants of Etheria, so they agreed for that. If more of these creatures ever came to the planet, they would become a real nuisance to all beings. living here. When she thought about it, she felt a strange, malicious joy. There were also several short and muscular beings, whose men all wore beards and the women in braids. One of them, his name was Virsek, was Igzar's second in command. He wore heavy armor in which he appeared to be twice his normal size and was roasting some sausages with a strange self-propelled Grill. So she approached him, he waved at her and said.

„Good to see you Comrade General! Do you want a sausage? They are really very good! I think they even contain meat.„ He waved a sausage in her face, it smelled really appetizing.

„Maybe later? For now, I'd like to talk about your commander. How is Igzar's health ? „ She asked carefully, unsure how the deputy would react to the question about his commander. Virsek Waved his hand and said.

„For now, he's sulking and lying on his bunk, but his pride is hurt more than his body. It must be admitted that the girl arranged it well. I only heard about her, but I never expected that she was even scarier than her uncle, although on the other hand the black

cat has recently become more snappy than dangerous. „ He laughed and knocked over one of the sausages.

„Eti is just weird. I wish you had met her Sister. Catra has almost conquered this world, and believe me, there's only one person better at fighting than her, her wife, although Catra was always much more cunny.” She answered

„Oh yes, that second girl. Well I knew their mother. After all, she was very dangerous, but also absolutely unpredictable. She was also not interested in strategy or politics. Sometimes I have the impression that she fought for the sake of fighting, and she didn't care who she fought for or why.„ Suddenly Virsek hesitated. „This is the older one, right? Well, of course the older one, which Another girl she could be!” He laughed, and she had the strange feeling that something very important was being said here, but she wasn't sure what.

”Listen, tell your boss that Captain Moonshadow will be arriving soon and it would be nice if he was there in relatively good condition. „ she said, trying to sound authoritative and professional, which was not easy when the other person was baking sausages. If only they didn't smell so wonderful.

„Maybe you can give one, you know, for the road.„ She asked and Virsek gave her a dark sausage.

„ It's black pudding, try it. It's delicious.”

„What is it made of?„ She asked, looking at the black pudding suspiciously.

„Made from groats, blood and liver.„ he said, smiling broadly and she hesitated. But then she accepted the sausage, after all, they had eaten much weirder and worse things.

Now she had to find one person. It took her an astonishingly long time, though maybe she shouldn't have been surprised, after all, like her sister, Eti was great at hiding when she wanted to. Hinges aimlessly wandering around the castle, she asked her friend, This

strange, muscular red-haired girl. Her name was probably Lilka. She found her when she and the strange clone and his bot, were inspecting the supplies brought by her new allies. The girl liked to cook with this clone. She told her that Eti and Rosie went up to one of the towers and there they were on a date together or something. She nodded and went where she was told.

„You know, if you think about it, you can build a quite nice house here, plant flowers in the garden, buy a kennel for the Basilisk. In one word, set up a family warren.„ She said with absolute seriousness, making a semicircle with her metal hand. Rosie stood next to her, resting her head on her shoulder. They were staring at the plateaus stretching around Castle Crypto . She felt a bit better now, beating her uncle allowed her to release some of the anger that was in her heart. She knew that what she did would have serious consequences, Igzar would not forget it, but it was still better than letting him put them in corners This bastard was ruthless and hated opposition, so she had to show him how things were now She was one of the few people who knew that the old cat was alive, but she wasn't sure if he would come here in person.. Despite all his hatred towards the Lord Admiral, he was an extremely cautious Individual, and always tried to be more cunning than the Others. Of course, it also tied up his hands. In these last five years, no one has heard of him. He did not achieve any success, and this meant defeat for the warrior. That's why she knew that when she beat him and gave Scar command, his soldiers would not protest. Now they will be curious about what will come of it all. She knew one thing, that Scar was also fighting for a cause, although she wasn't sure what it was, but probably Comrade General didn't really know either.

Rosie looked around as well, giving her a dubious look.

„I have a few questions... First of all, I don't really like the idea of building a house in the mountains, where it's constantly stormy. Secondly, nothing will grow on these rocks. Third, I'm not sure keeping a basilisk in a kennel is a good idea. Fourthly, I know you

don't like birds, but the term family nest sounds better than warren and fifthly and most importantly... Why do you sound like you want to talk to me about starting a family... I don't want to sound bad, but we have been together since the day before yesterday? she asked. sign language, excluding gloves.

„You know, it's a matter of point of view, for example, such mayflies live one day and for such a relationship lasting a day and a half is real Eons!”

„Are you comparing me to a mayfly?„ her girlfriend She looked at her always with her arms on her chest. She made an offended face, but there was no anger in her eyes.

„You know, we are all part of one great web of life. So in a way you're a bit of a mayfly too.”

Rosie laughed in her strange way of whistling lightly. Then she said.

„You're playing such a fool again! You know, I have to get mad at you for something like that someday. But not yet, it's too early for the first quarrel.„ The white-haired girl hugged her, and she carefully responded with the same hug.

„I think I'm in love for the first time. But did you have any other girlfriends, apart from Itel, of course? Because I know you were together.„ Rosie asked. She hesitated before answering.

„It's not like that. I'm just not always good at showing friendship, and I thought that if I went to bed with her, she would be happy. I think I made everything worse. As for the others, there were several girls. For example, the daughter of Doctor Sidonius . Her name is Sari and she is very pretty.”

Rosie tilted her head and asked.

„Should I be jealous?”

She considered her answer.

„Well, I guess not, she's not here now, so you can't be jealous.„ she said, trying to answer carefully.

„It's not an answer! If she came here, how should I feel? and what does she look like?„ her girlfriend seemed a little irritated now, so she should probably calm down somehow.

„She has long black hair, shiny like obsidian in moonlight. Big dark green eyes and perfect facial features like those of a half-elf. A Since she is half a vampire, she has very nice white skin and perfectly straight teeth, apart from the fangs, of course.”

Rosie took a ride and dramatically turned to her. I guess she got angry? After all, she was honest with her... She guesswd that's what a relationship was all about?

„If I didn't know you, I should be angry. But doesn't it bother you that her father is a vampire…” her girlfriend seemed unsure

„Being a vampire is the least of his crimes... He sent my sister here..... But it was also thanks to him that I was able to fly here.Of course, he didn't do it out of good heart... He wanted us to find a certain virus. It is supposed to heal Captain Blazebringer, because he has the Arsenal of End of Time... But I don't think he would use it anyway. This is what Itel dreamed of, but I don't know why he would keep his promise... „ She tried to explain her friend's plan, and Rosie looked at her in amazement, then embraced her and kissed her.

„I love you for this weirdness, you know?„ She said after the Kiss. They stood hugged each other for a moment, and then Scar's voice rang out behind them.

„I don't think I'm interrupting anything, right? „ said the woman, smiling shyly. They pulled away from each other and, tilting her Head to the side, she answered.

„Not now, but you know, it might be different in the evening. If you're interested, we're not planning threesomes”

Scar opened her mouth in surprise and said.

„I didn't think about something like that, not with you anyway… What am I talking about now? I just wanted to tell you that Captain Moonshadow will be arriving soon... And it's probably a good thing if you were present, your uncle and your captain have already been notified.”

She nodded and kissed Rosie, then followed Comrade General. As they were walking, Scar suddenly asked.

„You know, Eti, I was wondering. One of your uncle's subordinates said something like this... And I would like to ask... There are no more like you... You, Catra, I mean.„ the dark”skinned woman smiled uncertainly at it.

The question brought back memories, memories she would rather forget. Because she was afraid of them. She curled into herself, hunched, and flattened her ears.

„Yes, there were two more of us, a long time ago. But they are gone. Only one was needed. That's all!„ Her voice was so cold and sharp at the same time that Comrade General did not press ...Only Rosie looked at her with compassion, so she embraced her and together they went to the landing pad.

Captain Moonshadow got out of the shuttle, looking around carefully. First officer Tonado jumped in front of her, his jump was daring, it must be admitted, and he was on the lookout for an ambush. Apart from her, there were also Boatswain Kaert and Second Officer Gydwa on board. They both looked like they didn't really want to find each other. Kaert was mainly suffering from a hangover, he drank a lot while celebrating their successful robbery. And Veska was grumpy as always. She looked at the castle, whose walls, almost reaching Storm swirling in the sky, rose in the distance, and felt something. As if a memory was emerging in her head. She visited here quite often, but she had

the impression that the last time she visited this place was many years ago, in relation with some very important event. It was something sad, she remembered, with some people being mad at her for something. It was related to her previous visits, during which she proposed something to a certain couple... The proposal concerned something extremely important. One of the people had long purple hair, and the other was extremely petite, barely reaching her waist. She felt guilty about that event, although she actually had no idea what had happened. She only knew that she was responsible for it, and that she didn't tell anyone about it... But there were also other secrets related to this castle... She couldn't remember them now... These memories were like stars in the sky... Seemingly within reach, but at the same time far away. She shook her head, because such thoughts made no sense now anyway.

She saw that several people had come out to get her, better today this whole dark-skinned woman with a strange adamantine staf in her hand, who was looking at her uncertainly. Apart from her, Bina was also there , smiling halfheartedly. Eti and Rosie stood next to each other and the white”haired girl held her hand. The person she didn't expect was the grim Pahtra. He was tall, had black fur and was covered with scars. One of his hands was bandaged and the other cybernetic was clearly damaged. He looked familiar to her, so she thought for a moment and finally understood. This was Igzar, leader of the Shadows of Tarak. From what she had heard, he should have been dead by now, but apparently the rumors about his fate were exaggerated.

However, before she could greet anyone, a small figure in a heavy bionic suit jumped at her.

„It's great that you're already captain!„ Tirin hugged her tightly. She smiled back at the girl and set her down on the ground.

„Did they treat you well here?„ She asked, looking at the rest with a somewhat feigned menacing look, and Eti answered.

„We didn't eat her, although it would be difficult. I guess she would have to be baked like a crab and removed from the shell. Terribly not practical, because she is very skinny, and there wouldn't even be enough meat for one meal.”

Everyone looked at the cat-like girl who seemed to be saying all this with a dead seriousness. Finally, Bina cleared her throat and then spoke.

„Good to see you, Captain Moonshadow... Queen Angela? Where I'm sure what I should call you now. This scary one here is Igzar ...„ said the captain-clone

„Yes, I know who he is. You can be very useful here, Igzar.„ She interrupted the burgundy-haired woman.

„Does that mean she's a fucking queen?„ Menancing Pahtra asked angrily , but Eti gave him a very cold look.

„Your opinion, uncle, is of little importance here now. Remember whether you do this for work.” There was a hardness in the cat-like girl's voice that didn't suit her at all.

„Anyway, we have a lot of things to discuss, the situation has become more complicated, as you can probably see, and we have to find a way to get out of it all, and also get Catra out of her father's clutches.„ Bina said.

„Talk without me, I want to rest a bit. Itel and Scar will take care of everything.„ added Eti

She nodded in response, and followed the others to the council room.

Bina, probably of all those present in the room, felt the most comfortable in the place where they conferred. She was short, low ceilings didn't bother her , and she was used to this type of environment. Atrax was an industrial nightmare, cramped in a

building decorated with Gothic ornaments and gargoyles, But she liked this place. She grew up among the shadows and narrow streets of her home planet, which created a real maze, although not like those in that a castle, it must be admitted that its owners, or perhaps rather builders, must have had a very strange idea of functional space. As she got to know their last heiress, the architecture of this building reflected very well how they thought. Worse is that this Lonnie insisted on playing army. She wasn't surprised that her kids liked it. Itel had always admired Igzar and this kind of people for their discipline and organization. She always tried to learn from something, and here she met an army led by a girl of her age. A girl who had similar experiences to her, or at least that's what the elf thought. Bina, however, felt as if she had let them down... She wanted them to find peace and start living a normal life, especially Eti. But dammed Shadow Weaver sent them here herself, probably to make it easier for her to control them. From what she had heard about her, she had the need to control everything and everyone. In this, she reminded her of her father. He also treated his daughters not as persons, but as unruly parts of his own body. In fact, she wondered if he had the right technology like Horde Prime, wouldn't he control them in the same brutal way? She wondered if the Dark Sorceress had opposed the mad tyrant simply because she saw him as a threat to her rule over others, especially her daughters. Perhaps Eti was intended to be Catra's substitute, although she did not notice that the woman was trying to subjugate her feline protégé. Truth be told, her influence on the scout wasn't that bad. It even occurred to her that she wanted to atone for her sins in some way, that by being nice to Eti, or at least by treating her decently, she would somehow make up for how much she had hurt the other one. She didn't know Catra, but she had heard a lot about how children were treated in the Fright Zone. But she also knew well that such experiences could not simply be explained to others. You have to Experience it. Therefore, it was a terrifying irony that the fates of both sisters were so similar. Both had been broken in childhood, and both had only escaped from the darkness thanks to outside help, although as for Eti, she still

wasn't sure if she had managed to Suppress the darkness in her heart.

For now, however, the dark sorceress was not around, because she was in captivity of her former ward and daughter, so she did not matter. A much bigger problem was presented by Igzar , safe and sound. She didn't expect the old cat to survive. Eti didn't tell anyone about it, even Itel didn't know anything. The scarred Pahtra had always both irritated and arouse her respect, but now he looked like, Oh well. beaten cat. She always knew that Eti had a very cold relationship with her uncle, even though they hadn't known each other for very long. She remembered well that during those few days they were together, Igzar didn't even bother to gave her name. From the beginning, he made her understand that he was the one in this relationship who gave orders and she had to obey him. He didn't hide the fact that he was just another tool in his fight against Antares. Despite everything, she was slightly shocked when she found out that her protégé had beaten the mercenary commander. She knew that if Eti lost, old Pahtra would have no mercy for her, and even if he didn't kill her, he would at least mutilate her. She wasn't sure how long the girl had managed to subdue this old veteran, but she feared that sooner or later she might want to exact Revenge on his niece. On the other hand, there was little chance of him doing it while the Lord Admiral was around. His hatred was too strong.

Captain Moonshadow sat at the table, slouching slightly. She was so tall that in this room her head would hit the ceiling. Her servant, Veska, even cringed. This was not a room for members of her species. Skittrmander stood on a raised chair, glaring at the others. Itel sat next to Lonnie, her arm still wrapped in a bandage. The elf seemed sad, even depressed. She wasn't surprised, after all, she got everyone in trouble because of her. In addition, she summoned Igzar without asking anyone for opinion. Old Pahtra looked at her grimly, as if she had helped his niece beat him up. Lonnie looked surprisingly professional for a girl her age, eager to lead a rebellion against the Righteous Queen and half-goddess who saved the universe.. Was it even possible to look professional in such a situation?

„I won't introduce myself because you probably know who I am better than me. For the past five years, I have been the Scourge for the Azlanti, one of the most dangerous pirates in the galaxy. Only recently did I learn that I was the ruler of this planet.„ She looked at Lonnie, who nodded and said.

„You once led a rebellion after yours was captured during battle in the Valley of Shattered Armor. I didn't know much about you, for us you were just a figure from propaganda posters. But yes, you were a queen. A great and wonderful queen who ruled this kingdom for centuries. Everyone thought you died when the portal was opened, which almost led to the destruction of this planet. From what I heard, you sacrificed yourself to save everyone. Many believed that you had suffered a fate worse than death. I know that because of this, Glimmer almost activated heart of Etheria... Almost causing the destruction of... Probably the entire Galaxy. That was one of the reasons I fought with your daughter. I was, and still am, angry that she was willing to risk all of our lives for victory... But now, I feel like I wouldn't be better on my own. I have formed an alliance with the Shadow Weaver and other forces that do not have the well”being of our planet at heart.

The pirate with cybernetic wings frowned.

„Shadow Weaver… I remember that name... It was a person I both hated and felt sorry for.”

The Comrade General nodded.

“Yes, she was the right hand of Hordak , the leader of the horde. she raised Adora and Catra … And you too. She instilled fear in all of us, she was responsible for the worst of the Horde. She was a powerful sorceress who was once Cursed because of something she did. Everyone thought she died just like you, also sacrificing herself for others. But that was also one of her lies...”

The captain looked at Lonnie thoughtfully.

„Not necessarily, in the galaxy death is not as irreversible as you think here. In order not to look far, I just need to mention Dr. Sidonius.„ She looked significantly at the rest, and Bina began to explain.

„He's an ancient vampire. He is a scientist known throughout the galaxy. He financed our expedition here. He wanted us to find a certain artifact that would help heal a Captain Blazebringer. He is an extremely mysterious person who has a gigantic warship, the Ancient Void Galleon. He's one hell of a mystery dude. He has been alive for hundreds of years, but few have seen his face, it is not even known what species he is, but he has the Arsenal of End of the Time... It is supposedly the most terrible collection of weapons in the galaxy, although even less is known about it than about its owner.„ Now she looked at Itel. The elf took a deep breath and said.

„It was supposed to be a way to defeat the Swarm. Dr. Sidonius said he would help us convince Blazebinger to side with us against the Swarm. If so, we would have saved billions. No one would end up like our families again. Just like us... „ the girl lowered her head. „I would do anything to make it happen."

She sighed sadly and said.

„Itel, we don't even know if this Arsenal really exists, let alone that the Doctor will want to convince the Captain to your cause. He could have simply lied to you.

„Doctor Sidonius usually keeps his word. He just promises only things from which he will get some benefit.„ Said Captain Moonshadow. „He was the one who interrogated me for Azlanti and he was the one who sent me the equipment that helped me escape from captivity, but before that he implanted not entirely true memories in my mind. For example, that Adora's sword belongs to me and that I should get it back... „ she looked at Itel. „I have no doubt that he would enable you to speak with Captain Blazebringer. He would love to solve the Swarm problem. Not out of pity, but out of pure pragmatism. When you are such a long-

lived being, you have to take into account that the great problems of the world will sooner or later also affect you. But that's all, if he really cared about what would happen to the rest of the universe's inhabitants, he would try to convince Captain Blazebringer to help him.„ Even though the woman was wearing a mask, looking at the wrinkles around her eyes. she noticed that he was smiling, and rather sadly.

„But Captain Blazebringer is sick, he has nanite mold. That's why he can't help us!„ exclaimed the Elf with a trembling voice, as if she already knew that her argument was untenable.

„Maybe you're right, but this is all too convenient for Dr. Sidonius.„ She said, looking at her ward, who looked as if she was about to cry.

„So why did we come here? You could have protested... „ The solarian's voice broke as she spoke to her. She sighed and answered the girl.

„Because you would have figured out how to get here anyway, you are already an adult and I can't forbid you to do anything. At least I have control over what you do.”

„And Eti? Was that about her too? True? Did you want her to find her family?„ The elf looked at her carefully. She thought about her answer. She couldn't tell her the whole truth, not now. They weren't ready for the truth.

„Partially, although I was sure whether the girl really survived. But not only. Some of you hoped that you would find solace in such a place. That you will be able to forget about everything that happened to you. „ She closed her eyes sadly.„ But well, it happened differently, and actually regardless of you. The Lord Admiral would have arrived anyway, maybe a little later.

„What's going on with this Swarm?„ asked the general, obviously wanting to change the subject. Everyone looked at her, trying to

explain to her something that was incomprehensible to people who lived in such isolation.

„The Swarm These are billions of creatures traveling through the galaxy and devouring everything in their path. It's very hard to drive away this plague, and you can't beat them. I was on a planet, Kesler , that was attacked by them, so you can believe me that there is no more dangerous enemy. Me and Bina know exactly what they can do... This girl too.„ Igzar said, looking at Itel. she don't think he even remembered his name.

„That was a nightmare. The worst moments of my life... No, the training was worse. I didn't have any friends on Kesler . I haven't seen the worst either. But my kids lost everything... „ she looked at Itel, who pursed her lips. „But that doesn't concern you anymore. The Swarm is far away and unlikely for anyone here to encounter it.„ she said and smiled.

„ Unfortunately, you're wrong... „ Ireanis said in a voice as serious as she had ever heard before...

She was so thirsty. But she had to be sober, because the fate of so many beings rested on her shoulders... Why did Shadow Weaver get caught? And left everything on her head! She had a hard time coping with herself... Now she had to complete her mission, even though she didn't even know all the details... After talking to the dark sorceress's old friends, she went to the ship, where she tried to find something to soothe, but this creature living in the aquarium he didn't let her open the door to the studio, where the supplies of alcohol were hidden. And then she felt a darkness approaching the city... It was all-encompassing, as if it wanted to consume everything in its path... This darkness was alien, unnatural... It was something she had never encountered in her life, but then came an evil she knew all too well. She sensed the thing that had once broken her... Turned her into the pathetic drunk she was now. The only witness to her betrayal. The reason that she abandoned her companions... She left them to die. For

them to become undead abominations... She tried to correct her mistake, but instead she traveled through time and space and found herself on Kesler. She barely escaped with her life, and Bina and the Rest took care of her, because in this new world she was helpless like a child, almost like a blind kitten that someone had abandoned in the wild. It was as if she had the opportunity to start her life over again... She took advantage of it, becoming a pathetic drunk who was despised by everyone.

For years, she treated this place, these times, as a foreign land to which she had been banished . She tried to be useful, helping Bina's kids when she was sober. She didn't always succeed. These weren't her times, and most of the knowledge she had was useless now. The spells also worked differently now , the magic wasn't as powerful as before. Recently she even started to wonder if it was related to the same Heart, but she couldn't check it. She didn't know what she wanted to do with her life, except spend the rest of it half-living. Maybe it would be best for her, she didn't hurt anyone else, she didn't disappoint. Then Miss Daisy, or rather Shadow Weaver, introduced her to her plan. Both women were, let's be honest, not very happy that they had only themselves to rely on. Two drunkards and traitors were now going to save the world. That in itself sounded so idiotic it made me want to drink. Despite everything, she listened to the dark Sorceress and stopped drinking. It was a real torment, especially since she had such a huge responsibility. But she persevered in sobriety. But then she discovered that she, Ashaq the Annihilator, had appeared on Etheria she realized that she would no longer be able to escape into drunkenness. It became personal. She could finally atone for her mistakes, her sins, find revenge that she had never even dreamed of. She just had to convince the rest of us how serious the situation was. So, fighting fear and self-contempt, she entered the meeting room, where the conversation turned to the topic of the Swarm. When she spoke, everyone looked at her. The only one who didn't look at her with confusion was the one Lonnie, she remembered her name well, who was in charge.

„Ireanis, Listen, this is a serious meeting. I know you want to help, but it's better what you do when you sober up.”

„She's sober Bina, she hasn't had a drink since we landed here. Shadow WeaveraAlso, they both stuck together. „ Itel explained. The captain of their ship frowned, then glared at her.

„You knew about her... For how long! „ said the woman with burgundy hair sharply.

„Since I stopped drinking, but then you order me to be kicked out. Listen to what I have to say, I know I haven't given you any reason to trust me yet, but do it this once, okay? If you do this, you can save a great many. The captain's husband, and her sister-in-law, listened to me, so you can try it too, okay?„ She said pointing to Captain Moonshadow, who looked at them confused.

„But he... He's dead.„ The pirate captain said with pain in her voice, but then everyone except Itel looked at her.

„You do not know anything?!„ Bina said with surprise... „ Mikah is alive, I met him in Brightmoon ... You can ask Tirin, she also talked to him. He did not introduce himself to her as the Royal Consort, but he did give her his name. A rather short, athletic man in his fifties who had a wizard's staff.

Lonnie nodded.

„Yes it's true. Adora freed him when she came to the beast island for Entrapta . It's a familiar story.”

„But how... He died during the battle...„ Said Captain Moonshadow, leaning on the table top.

„Do you mean that old man we met in the forest?„ The solarian asked, looking at her with surprise.

„He was sent to the Beast Island, just like everyone else, including unruly citizens... He miraculously survived there. I don't know what he's doing now, but from what I've heard, he's a very sad man.„ Comrade General added at the end.

„Does he… Does he know about me. About who I am… Who have I become?”

Bina nodded and said in an apologetic tone.

„I told him everything... Also about what you did on Icarus. I'm sorry, maybe I wasn't gentle enough, but I never thought we'd meet again.”

The former queen nodded sadly.

„My memories... The Doctor distorted them. He made me believe that the sword belonged to me, that it had always been mine. Even now it's hard for me to get out of it. Just the thought of abandoning it hurts me. I thought Adora abandoned me in that place. I still don't remember much. But I have to do one thing to end it all.„ She reached under her coat and pulled out a broken sword. Veska growled at this, and Skittermander inhaled sharply.

„Here are the remains of the sword of protection... I believe they will be more useful to you than to me.„ She moved what was left of the weapon towards the Comrade General, who was staring at this gift with wide eyes.

„It's very nice of you to put these two in there and all, but there are other things I need to talk about.„ the elven sorceress interjected.

„Yes, you said something about a Swarm.„ Lonnie She looked in her direction, taking her eyes off the gun.

She took a deep breath and began to recount what Shadow Weaver had told her. About the First Ones, that they control the Swarm, and how they intend to send it to this planet. Everyone listened to her attentively. Itel's face showed growing terror, and Bina clutched her temples with her fingers. Captain Moonshadow looked at her seriously, and a Igzar bristled. He looked like he wanted to hit her, but he usually looked like that, so she wasn't sure if something had changed. Even the Comrade General

seemed frightened, although she had no idea what they were dealing with.

„And that's why you'll go on an adventure with Hordaki, Mikah and your sister-in-law, and with that we'll save the world... Or the entire universe!„ she said and did a pirouette.

„I'm going with you.„ Captain Moonshadow declared in a voice that brooked no objections.

„Oh, that's a great idea, I could to teleport now!„ she said with delight. They took her seriously, it was amazing! No one ever took her seriously!

„First I need to give orders to my subordinates, this ship will be at your disposal for some time.„ replied the pirate captain.

„What are we supposed to do? „ Itel asked, looking around. „I guess we should warn the others?”

„Shadow Weaver She's definitely done it before, but I'm not sure they believed her... Catra, you can't even imagine how she can hate her. But there was nothing they could do about it. But there is this ship, far away on the northern borders, the ancient ship of the First Ones is hidden under the ice. Our allies... Mi-Go offered to help us extract him, but the price they demanded... But fortunately, you can help us.„ She looked pleadingly at the others. Itel smiled and was about to say something, but she hesitated and looked at Bina . The clone woman nodded.

„We have some means... But it won't be easy... We don't know how to extract ships and... But we will help... Maybe we will also find what Dr. Sidonius was looking for. Maybe we could get Captain Blazebringer's help... „ The solarian's eyes sparkled. hope, but Bina answered her with undisguised skepticism in her voice.

„I wouldn't count on it, but any help will be useful.„ said the clone woman..

„So we are the ones who guard the safety of Etheria , or maybe even the whole of Universe...„ she said and looked at the others. „It's a bit ridiculous that I'm standing among you, but I'll try to stay hungry for such a noble company...„ she smiled wryly. Moonshadow Chapel She laughed briefly.

„This company includes a former queen turned pirate. A former gangster who became a caretaker of orphans' and smuggler. A former cadet serving in the army of the evil Empire who leads the rebellion and an orphan who wants to defeat the Scourge of the Galaxy. I won't even mention the terrorist and the Freedom Fighters in one. We are the ones who lost everything but still didn't give up, you fit perfectly here...„ She took a deep breath and stretched her hand to the middle of the table. „ Let's make an alliance that we will try to complete our mission together and save Etheria and perhaps the entire universe. I don't remember everything yet, but a lot of what this woman says rings true, so we have to find the first ones and neutralize them... Otherwise, they lost everything, again ... „ And one by one they put their hands on the table and swore, Each in their own way, although Igzar reluctantly. She was proud of herself for making it happen. But it didn't change the fact that she still wanted to get drunk.

Chapter End Notes

> You've been waiting for this chapter for a while. What do you think about Ireanis?

Extremely valuable treasures - part one

He landed blows one by one, shouted battle cries, defeating countless enemies. It aroused admiration and touched the heart! Both male and female. He defended those he loved, proving to them that he was worthy of them. He was undefeated, Unstoppable, invincible, he was… He tripped and hit his head on the edge of the door. He let out a short cry of pain and started rubbing the area where he had hit himself. He was in pain, he probably had a tumor. So much for Heroic Feats. In truth, In fact, it could have been worse... He could have, for example, cut something off. He looked at the sword and then the walls of the corridors of Castle Crypto where he left many scratches. He had to admit that the blade was extremely sharp. He wasn't sure how sharp Adora's sword was, his former friend wasn't in the habit of cutting everything around her, especially other people. In fact, he didn't remember her cutting anyone in half, not even Horde Prime, although he deserved it. He also didn't want to slash or chop anyone. At least someone alive and feeling pain... But he wanted to be a hero and he knew that with this weapon he would finally become one! Someday, when he trained enough... He trained a lot, for days, maybe weeks... He just would have to figure out a way to find time to train without anyone noticing... Especially Lonnie... His girlfriend was naturally suspicious. It would be difficult hide it from her... Maybe it's worth wearing an eye patch. When he says. that he lost an eye, he will have an explanation, so that he does not have to participate in the life of the rebellion. He would ask Eti to say that she scratched out his eye. Catra finally scratched out Oktavia's eye ... The problem was that Eti had no claws. It was a bad idea anyway, they would either give him a cybernetic eye or they would start asking too many questions. Maybe he'll come up with some horribly contagious disease that will force everyone to leave him alone... He sighed, looking at the blade. All these ideas were stupid. Sooner or later, everyone will

find out. It didn't matter anyway. He will never be a hero. Even with this sword, he was just himself. How could he imagine that he would be more than he is? He may have succeeded once, but it was an accident. He just had a bit of luck, that's all. Maybe say give the sword to someone else? But to whom? Adora already had hers, although it wasn't the same sword that she once found in the forest. He had n't thought much about his old friend since he discovered what that sword could do. He was afraid of the implications, of what might connect them, of who he really was... He knew very little about the First Ones, only that Entrapta was searching for the artifacts they left behind, and that they had turned their planet into a weapon. Did that also scare him, or was he, like the heroine of the Galaxy, just a tool that his compatriots wanted to use? Maybe he should really return this Sword to its original owners? Mr. Lance would be sad if he did this, but it would probably be better this way. He would also tell Adora his suspicions about who he is. Except he would have to go to Brightmoon , and in this situation that would be impossible. Maybe he'll give that sword back to those terrifying Beetle Mushrooms? Although it wouldn't be a good idea either, it's better that such things don't fall into the hands of these creatures... So it would be best if he just threw this one into a chasm... It would be difficult for him to part with it, but he probably had no choice. At least he'll think it over for a few days. And during this time he would train, nothing bad would come of it, he just had to be careful, but it shouldn't be difficult, because right now everyone had more important things to worry about. These Shadows, for example. The soldiers Itel called were terrible. They personified what he had always feared. They were armed to the teeth, seemed ruthless, and looked at him as if they wanted to make sausages out of him. In fact, one of them even fry some of them all the time. Their commander-in-chief was Catra's uncle, and he had everything that terrified him about his feline friend, but multiplied ten times over. For now, he listened to Lonnie, but only because his niece intimidated him... But he wasn't sure how long it would last, and when he wanted to regain power, Lonnie could be in serious trouble... he guessed he would keep the sword, just in case .

Then, as he was trying to put his blade into its sheath without cutting himself, which made me think of Lonnie, he heard a short scream, and he jumped up, hitting his head on the ceiling, the ceilings were very low in some places here, and he started looking around. He was deep inside the castle, a place where no one usually went. They had a map of the castle on their datapads, but it wasn't complete, and he often had the impression that the corridors of this castle changed themselves whenever someone didn't visit them for a long time. Sometimes they terrified him, he was afraid that they would eventually change so much that he would not be able to return to the rest and would be trapped here forever. He will never see those he loves again and will wander alone for eternity, trapped in darkness. He often wondered if this castle was haunted by ghosts or other horrors. Lonnie always told him that ghosts and other such imaginary creatures don’t exist... But then he saw that thing in Brightmoon and realized that the world wasn't that simple. That creature was something indescribably terrible. Compared to him, Shadow Weaver would be like... Kyle compared to Shadow Weaver... This creature was worse than the most terrible beasts from the dark Sorceress's fairy tales. There was something else there too, something old and emanating death. He didn't have time to look at it, but it was something Dead, a denial of life, a creature of the power opposite to that he was then filled. It felt like it was ready to absorb the energy of all living things around it. Was there anything similar in this castle? Theoretically he should be able to handle it while he had the sword, what if it somehow attacked him before he drew it? But, he felt he had to check it out, because what if one of his friends came across this creature? He took a few deep breaths to calm himself down, which didn't work, but it never did, and moved forward into the Dark Halls.

„He's definitely here somewhere, you just have to look around.„ Eti said, looking around. Rosie looked at her and saw her girlfriend sniffing ostentatiously.

„It must be strange to have such a sense of smell.„ She asked the girl she loved. She herself had a better sense of smell than most people, but Eti had a phenomenal sense of smell.

„It's completely normal, others just have a bad sense of smell.„ The cat-like girl replied and leaned over the floor.

„Catra Possess about eight times better than the regular one, but due to being in a Fright Zone where everything was saturated with very unhealthy fumes, hers probably became significantly duller . „ said Entrapta, walking next to them. The purple-haired princess was clearly excited to return to her castle, but also that Eti had promised her that she would be able to examine her hand. Now, however, for unknown reasons, her girlfriend insisted that they need to find Kyle because she also has something interesting. It wouldn't bother her, she even liked the blond-haired boy, but the corridors were getting more and more disturbing. They reminded too much of the place where they found the Heart Gift ... It was a very sad memory that she didn't want to go back to for now, she just wanted to enjoy the presence of her girlfriend and the fact that they were together... Although the inventor princess would definitely be happy if she met that AI... Although, on the other hand, she had already noticed that Entrapta was very talkative and extremely honest, so there was a chance that she would tell that being the truth about what happened to her mothers... What you did, however, was huge, and surprisingly she had the impression that even the former mistress of this castle, she wasn't entirely familiar with its placement, so she wasn't sure why Kyle was so deep.

„I can smell a lot of smells here, grease, rats, cockroaches, and almond-scented soap... but this is Rosie... This is very strange...”

„Are all castles here like this? I know that in the empire, some people build huge palaces and even modify space stations to look like cathedrals, palaces or ziggurats. all covered with ornaments relating to our… to Azlantean Culture.„ Said Tirin through the voice synthesizer, walking slightly behind and looking around the corridors. They took her with them at their own request. The

strange girl in the bionic armor seemed to be lost among the soldiers and cadets, and she didn't like open spaces, so she couldn't even go beyond Castle Crypto to explore the mountainous area. On the other hand, there wasn't much to see here, while all of Etheria was a very pretty place, even the Crimson Wastes, those mountains were barren and bleak, She still felt guilty for almost killing that girl, though Tirin didn't seem to hold grudges about what happened.

„Azlanti Empire? Oh that's fascinating, can you tell me more about it?„ Entrapta asked, taking her eyes off the datapad . „They were the ones who imprisoned Queen Angela , weren't they?”

Tirin lowered her head and spoke softly.

„I don't know much about my... About the empire. I spent almost my entire life on Jadehell in a labor camp. I only visited a few cities located in the polar regions, where the climate is more bearable and poisonous spores are not so ubiquitous. They can go outside there, as long as the weather is good, without fear for their health... The Empire is very old, older than Absalom Station. Originates from the Lost Golarion. Our ancestors come from a Colony founded just before the star fell... When the Starstone arrived on the planet...

„Starstone?„ asked the inventor princess, pulling a girl as petite as herself towards her. „Tell me about him! Is this an artifact or the name of an meteoroid?”

„Actually, it's both, because it's a magical stone that once hit the planet and destroyed the Azlanti Empire there and almost any civilization. It was very powerful, thanks to it Aroden the Last of Azlantii, extracted the island of Absalom. We even have a video about it on the ship.„ she said, smiling at the inventor.

„Catra She really doesn't like it when people talk about such things. It reminds her of Horde Prime. But I would like to hear more about them. I used to not be interested in such social issues, but now I have learned how important they are. After all,

when we get to know each other better, we will then become friends faster and cooperate easier, right?„ The purple-haired woman said, looking a little calmer than usual.

„Thus, three gods were created thanks to this stone, not counting Aroden Iomadae known as the inheritor, Nogrober known as the reaper reputation and Caiden known as the lucky drunk. „ She explained, trying to sound as respectful as possible, after all, she was actually representing the university here.

„Why don't you count this Aroden?„ Entrapta asked.

„Because He's dead. He died thousands of years ago on the Lost Golarion, and no one knows how it happened, except that it shook the entire world.„ she explained to the Woman with purple hair.

„So Gods can die? „ asked the inventor princess. She seemed concerned. She slowly nodded, and then Eti interjected.

„You have another one here, but you don't know about it.”

Entrapta looked at her in surprise, then began dictating.

„Number seven thousand four hundred one In the archeology category. Today, quite by accident, I made an amazing discovery. There is a truly wonderful artifact on Etheria. According to my sources of information, he has the power to create beings called gods, It probably has something to do with She-Ra's power... It cannot be confirmed for sure yet, further research is necessary ... „ the woman stopped dictating and began to rub her hands and hair.

„I guess that's cool?„ she looked around uncertainly, and Eti started sniffing more intensely.

„I think I smell something, two scents, one is cheap cologne, Blonde boy uses it because he think his Boyfriend or Girlfriend likes it... But the other scent is weird, it reminds me of Wrongdak, but not quite. It's like something has been added to it, and it's also somehow familiar. It's really weird... You know, I really don't

like the unknown, because the unknown usually wants to hurt you.” The cat girl said, and flattened her ears, Wagged her tail nervously, and placed her gloved hand on the gun.. Surprisingly, Entrapta also seemed concerned, although she had seemed very carefree so far.

„Entrapta, This is your castle, you know it best. Do you know what it could be?„ she looked at the purple-haired woman. She didn't look at her like that, she just looked at her datapad , as if she didn't pay attention to them. So she approached her and asked.

„Did something happen?„ she looked at it carefully. All the energy and vitality she had just exuded evaporated.

„I never really explored this castle... I always felt lost in it. The feeling that I was an intruder here, but at the same time I didn't want to leave it for a long time. I didn't feel at home here. I felt even more out of place... So maybe we can change the subject? This hand of yours. You don't even realize how amazing she is!„ She started looking at this strange prosthesis, as if she had completely forgotten about her previous questions. Tirin looked at them questioningly, but shrugged in response.

„Oh, you don't even know how cool she is. There are signs of the First Ones on it, but they are not visible. The doctor claimed he didn't know what they meant, but I didn't believe him. Kyle can read them, and there are similar Signs on his sword.” Eti said with some pride on her face, and Entrapta looked at her with wide eyes. Her mouth was also open, as if she didn't believe what she heard.

„So he can read the First One’s writings? It's amazing! How does he do it! So far, it has not been possible to break it in any way. Even though Adora tries to help translate, nothing can see in these signs what she sees! It's like this language doesn't want to be understood. As if it was created so that only those who were the First Ones could understand it. Which actually fits with what we know about him... „ She was talking to herself out loud, and then she stopped and looked at them in a strange way.

„Are you implying that because Kyle can read a First Ones language, that means he is... one of them?„ She said, barely containing the exclamations of excitement in her voice. Her girlfriend shrugged and said.

„I know Dr. Sidonius is interested in them. Rechiza, the woman who traveled with us, claimed that she could read this language thanks to the implants the doctor had installed on her. I don't know if he installed them on himself. That's why I suspect he was lying about not knowing what was written on my hand.”

The inventor princess listened carefully to what the cat girl was saying and thought about it.

„Is it possible that Kyle somehow came into possession of such implants and installed them without anyone's knowledge? That means he has great technical skills, I feel jealous when I think about it”

„I've known Kyle for a while , and he's not a person. who would be able to perform the implantation procedure on himself.„ She explained to the purple-haired woman, who screamed.

„Do you understand what this means? He's just like Adora! In some ways, they even look similar. Do you think it is…”

„ My brother-in-law or something? „ Eti asked clearly curiously... „Poor guy, he doesn't even know what a wonderful and wonderful family he has!„ The girl told her calmly, happy with this thought.

„But should we spread the word?„ She asked the other girls, looking at the, but Captain Moonshadow's protégé added.

„I have heard a little about the civilization of the First Ones, some say that we are their heirs... That all their works belong to us, including the cities on Abalon .

„You have the First Ones cities!„ cried the inventor princess with a voice full of unbridled Joy.

She was about to answer, but then there was a distant scream.

„We go there! „ Eti exclaimed, flattening her ears... Something worried her... Without any objections, they ran together.

Nightgale knelt down, crushed by indescribable suffering. This attempt was particularly strong, it was clear that Glimmer this time decided that she would not give up and would try to gain control of the Moonstone until she succeeded. Apparently, she really needed to regain her former power. There was nothing strange about it. She had to chase the Shadow Weaver, she was the greatest threat to her kingdom, her twisted apprentice and an inhuman monstrosity. the ability to teleport was very useful to her... But she couldn't give up, not only because then the queen would have a chance to track them down, although not in this castle, but also because she would then slowly start to die. She had to fight if she wanted to survive. She was fully aware that it only took a few minutes, but it felt like it lasted for hours. The Queen was a strong woman, but she had suffered so much in her life... Her father's people were created to endure hardships and tribulations that no one else could. And her mother, well, she had been in the same conditions as her for thirty years… So finally Glimmer had to give in. She breathed a sigh of relief when the indescribable pain suddenly subsided. She was all wet, panting heavily, and lay down on the metal floor of the castle. This time I succeeded, and she suspected that for some time the queen would not have the strength to fight her again...

Getting a comma here wasn't that difficult. She never gave Lonnie a full map of the castle, well, she was taught that you should always have an advantage over a potential enemy, And anyone can be your enemy, Even if they are now your friend. Castle Crypto It had several hidden entrances, one of them was relatively easy to access, although it required great caution due to the motion sensor connected to the Ancient dart thrower capable of piercing even armor plates. Fortunately, thanks to her Magic, she had several ways to bypass them. Getting to Dryl was much more

difficult. The cultists provided her with a means of transportation, a small one-person anti-gravity from Icarus vehicle, but she had to get there on her own, although she could have used the help of local worshipers of the Great Old Ones. She did this. Anyway, she stopped in a certain village where the inhabitants celebrated rituals once a month in honor of Nuclear Chaos. They seemed normal at first glance, but only to an eye as trained as hers were the obvious signs visible. Strangely fatalistic cheerfulness , longing glances at the sky, strangely rhythmic way of speaking, countless tics. The village was small, only a few buildings. From what I heard, the largest habitat of ancient cults was Thymor , a town with numerous festivals and exceptionally richly celebrated holidays... Ironically, it was one of the first towns that Horde Prime decided to chip . Sometimes you wondered if this was part of a grand plan of Creeping Chaos. After all, the Great Outer God looked far into the future in his predictions; some of his conspiracies began thousands of years ago. Perhaps the inhabitants of that city were to be just one of countless victims, on the way to the fulfillment of Nyarlathotept's Great Plan.

A much bigger problem was the guards of Brightmoon, which were put on full alert. This is where Illusion Magic came in handy, thanks to which she was able to slip through unnoticed. The most irritating thing was the journey that had to be taken to the right castle. Castle Crypto was not only a tangle of corridors, but also a maze created in an extremely impractical way. The corridors twisted and turned at random places, the stairs sometimes led up only to go down, and she was more and more convinced that both the castle and her map were changing every time she was almost sure she knew the logic behind the builders who created this place. Eventually, however, she managed to get to her second, hidden, room. When she saw her great possessions, this private one, she felt like crying. Old and almost worn-out clothes that the real Scarlet had given her, some iron rations in case she ever had to leave this place, which was what was happening, a few books, slightly truncated volumes about the dark affairs, and a few gifts received from Scarlet. An acorn man, a wreath of twigs and a metal cup stolen from the Fright Zone. She wondered for the first

time whether she loved the former cadet. She wasn't sure. Her memories of those times were incomplete, as if she was intoxicated by the life she was discovering. That short time after leaving the Fright Zone, when they were hiding together on the outskirts of the Whispering Forest, was so filled with fear and joy that everything seemed like a dream. She was intoxicated by the fact that she was alive. The emotions at the time were so new and overwhelming that she couldn't pinpoint what she was really feeling. Perhaps it was just infatuation of a creature rejected by the whole world. It was the only period in her life when she was truly happy... And then it ended unexpectedly, on a day that was a great victory for everyone. She wasn't sure if she would ever get Scarlet back…. Initially, this was her main goal, the most important reason why she did all these, often terrible, things. But it was also about something else... She wanted power and strength, to represent all the Great Mysteries of the world, to serve something greater than herself, to be appreciated and noticed, to no longer be a failure... She laughed and knelt down on the narrow mattress that served as my place of rest. in these moments if you wanted to take on your true form. She realized how much she had inherited from her parents, from both parents. Not only from her mother, who accepted her, but also from her father, who rejected her and banished her to the underworld of his kingdom. Most importantly, she inherited both their good qualities and, above all, their worst characteristics. It was while she was contemplating her cursed heritage that the attack came and she had to fight to maintain control of the Moonstone. It took her a few minutes to recover, during which she wondered if she should visit her old friends. It would be fair to them, but in this state it was also a big waste of time, of which she didn't have much... But if she didn't do it now, she would regret for the rest of her life that she hadn't had this conversation, perhaps the last one. On the other hand, she also had to find a certain place, then it was hidden among the tangle of corridors. It was located in a part of the castle that she had never explored, and what she knew she had known for many years and had not been visited, neither by the last lady of the place, nor by her parents. There was a node in the network and geomatics that wrapped around the

entire planet. There was supposed to be a terminal there that would allow connection to the planetary archive, which would then store some of the knowledge gathered by Light Hope. However, as she recently learned, using the archive can currently be very risky. She spoke to Lady Cala about her encounter with the ancient si, and she bluntly said that she had tried to use it to murder Adora. She claimed that the artificial intelligence was a creation of Mara and that it had a very bad experience with the death of its creator, and that it might be unstable now. She had the impression that the aristocrat was hiding something from her, some small nuance of the whole story, but she had no way of finding out. She still had a few hours before their contact, and she hadn't taken the mirror with her to Castle Crypto anyway, even in this form she didn't have the strength to carry it through all those corridors. She sighed, so she gathered all the strength she had left after that exhausting battle of wills with Glimmer, and headed up the winding and dark corridors. However, after just a few minutes she heard a scream. She immediately stopped and listened. You were aware that she were in one of the most mysterious places in all of Etheria . It may not have been R'lyeh or one of the Mi-Go colonies, but Entrapta's ancestors had secrets of their own. The Inventor Princess was a prime example of this. No one knew what happened to her parents, but during her stay in these mountains she talked to many of their inhabitants. She learned that once the parents of the former Lady of this place went on some expedition, leaving their minor daughter alone in the castle... Supposedly they were performing some task. commissioned by Queen Angela, who had visited the castle a few weeks earlier, although the former ruler Etheri had never told anyone why she had gone to this place, but now certain suspicions were coming to her mind... The Queen knew a lot about the First Ones, although no one knows exactly how much... Has she knew the dark truth? Was this the reason for her interest in this place? That ancient civilization left its mark on this building. It was called Castle Crypto for a reason Did this scream come from the "mouths" of the creations of Etheria's first colonizers? Or was it something much more sinister, a soul trapped in this maze that defies logic and common sense? She'll never know if she

doesn't check, and I thought it was worth checking because it came from the place she was going to check anyway... So, full of concerns, she went in that direction.

Dr. Moors felt extremely disappointed. His allies were untrustworthy. They received so many gifts from his masters, and yet they were constantly looking for ways to disobey their orders. He guessed they don't get much coffee, the sacrifice of one person who was their enemy. It wouldn't even be a sacrifice, after all, they actually wanted to save her, preserve her wonderful mind so that it could last for countless eons, gaining wisdom and learning secrets inaccessible to ordinary beings. Yes, the brain extraction procedure was terrible and changed the personality of the person who underwent it, but he think it made him a better person. He no longer felt the same emotions and desires as those with biological bodies. So why was the Comrade general so afraid to give them Entrapta ... She could have captured her once when she was in this city of Elder Things, but then he was able to forgive her because she was distracted by the others. more personal matters, and she was injured. But then, she formed an alliance with that damned Shadow Weaver, a woman who was willing to get rid of anyone who threatened her or her secret. How could she trust someone like that? Yes, the Mi-Go had secrets from her, but only because she had not yet proven, and probably never would, that she is trustworthy and capable of bearing such secrets. For now, however, they had not deceived her. Of course, it could not be ruled out that this would happen in the future, but after all, she was only a mortal... She was only important as long as she was useful. Unfortunately, her usefulness was slowly ending, also due to the fact that unfortunately his masters became less useful to her. The arrival of these mercenaries from outside the fallen Empire made the rebellion so dependent on the Mi-Go. The Comrade General captured the inventor princess and wasn’t already interested in giving her to his masters. There was a betrayal in this, someone would have to be punished like that one day, but the time would come ... For now, he had to sit quietly and look for an opportunity to take action. The goals of its rulers

remained unchanged. Obtaining that woman's brain was just one of them. He had to find a way to establish contacts with the rest of their race's diaspora, and secure this place. Mi-Go They were extremely wise, but this wisdom resulted from the fact that they were able to draw conclusions from the discoveries of other civilizations. And Etheria was one big mystery just waiting for you to dig in and taste the flesh of the Secrets it hides . But hey, maybe there were other allies with much more open minds. Those who will understand how important it is to solve the riddle of this planet. Unfortunately, even the Overseer couldn't avoid Memory Loss due to the Gap. Therefore, they had to make most of the discoveries on their own, but the allies he kept an eye on had access to ancient knowledge and terrible powers, thanks to which they would obtain the key to the great secret of Etheri.

But now he have to investigate a mystery. He had suspected something for a long time. This boy, Kyle and his sword... There was something strange between them. This young man had never been interested in weapons, had no desire to become a warrior, and now he carried this weapon absolutely everywhere. He also became more confident, but at the same time one could get the impression that he was constantly afraid of something. As if he had some secret, the discovery of which could have terrible consequences for him... Because there is something extremely surprising about it, after all, he have known him almost since I was a child and he was a person you could read like a book. He also had to know his secret, especially since it was somehow related to Scarlet. This woman was also more than it seemed at first glance. He respected her for her hunger for knowledge, and her open mind, which shrank from ancient secrets that the others would find even terrifying. She also seemed willing to cooperate, especially since she didn't feel the same way about him immediately as everyone else. But she also hid secrets, so she had her rulers, perhaps even more powerful and greater than his masters. Besides, and this was probably the most important thing, she wasn't Scarlet. Although he wasn't sure what her real identity was. Unlike the rebels, his artificial eyes saw things as they were, and he never rejected the truth, even when it seemed forcefully

impossible. He saw no reason to tell Lonnie about this. The Sorceress was potentially a much more valuable ally than the former ambulance. That's why he felt disappointed that there was a secret between her and Kyly that was beyond his reach. He had to discover him... That's why he followed this boy, to find out what he was up to... It wasn't difficult. His physique , if that word could be used to refer to a brain in a cylinder, was extremely difficult to see, especially in dark corridors. When he wanted to, he could move incredibly fast and silently, remaining almost unnoticed in the dark. Of course, tracking this kid wasn't hard. Kyle was tripping over his own feet. If the Horde were any more of a normal army, someone like that would be sent to serve in the rear. He was probably better trained than most men”at”arms on Etheria , but training him was a waste of time and resources. When he saw that the boy had simply started playing fencing, he wanted to sigh, although in his current state he couldn't do it. Well, if he wanted to play knight, or even She” Ra , that's his business. He didn't have time to watch some kid swing a sword. He was about to return to the upper part of the castle when a scream rang out. Intrigued, he began to listen. His hearing instruments were very advanced, so he easily discovered that the cry did not come from the humanoid's throat ... And at the same time, it resembled him very much... Only after a while he realized that the voice was synthesized, which made him curious, trying to be unnoticed by the young man, he followed towards the sound source...

Extremely valuable treasures - Part Two

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Rosie noticed that Eti was both curious and concerned. She may not have known her girlfriend for very long, she liked word Girlfrend very much, but she saw that almost nothing could scare or worry her. It was a matter of what she heard, after all, she had very sensitive hearing. She had no idea what it was like to hear, and sometimes she imagined that hearing was an almost supernatural power. It seemed to her that the vibrations, which she usually only felt, appeared in the heads of those who heard them as words... Really, you can't imagine a sense you never had... But what did Eti sense that outraged her so much? She knew that the two of them could face any threat. She shuddered as she remembered the night's fight with She-Ra. She didn't want to think about that fight, what it might have meant...

Entrapta ran after them, using her hair to help herself, she was surprisingly fast for a scholar. Tirin probably kept up with them thanks to her bionic suit. When they reached the intersection, something suddenly jumped out at them from a side corridor. It was headed towards Eti, so without thinking, she delivered a powerful blow to him, wanting to save her girlfriend. She heard a strangled scream and saw Kyle lying on the Floor.

„Oh no ! I did it again!„ she said in sign language, which her gloves translated.

„Brother-in-law, could you please stop bumping into my girlfriend and scaring her, because she is very sensitive, but she also hits hard and if she kills you, she will be very sorry!„ She said Eti as she gave herself over to the boy, fortunately he was breathing.

„Oh, that must have hurt, I know something about that.„ Tirin said. They helped the blond haired boy up, he didn't look that bad, she probably didn't even break any of his bones, although he'll have a terrible limo. But what will they say to Lonnie now?

„When I was a cadet, it happened to me several times.„ Kyle said, smiling before becoming serious and looking at Eti. „Why do you call me brother-in-law? Stop doing this! Lonnie might hear this!„ He was very scared. Eti turned her head to the side and said.

„Because , you know, my sister is Adora's wife, and she is one of the First Ones, and if you can also read their writing, then you are probably one of them too, or someone associated with them.. So you could say you're something like my brother-in-law.

The boy turned white as milk.

„You weren't supposed to tell anyone about this!„ He screamed at Eti with resentment in his voice.

„And if I met Anyone, I wouldn't tell him anything. Plus, a few things have happened recently. I discovered that my hand can do more than it seems, and the Sparkling Paw... She did something strange... And this sword of yours, I need to know the truth, and we have an expert.„ The cat girl pointed at Entrapta, who bowed courtly.

„But what do I have to do with it...„ Kyle said, looking at them pleadingly. Despite the questions, she had the impression that he knew what was going on.

„It's about your sword. The metal one, of course, is probably made by the First Ones since it has their inscriptions on the blade... „ Eti explained.

„And does he have a sword other than a metal one...„ Tirin asked, and Eti looked at her significantly, and she and Kyle blushed.

„Ah, that's the sword George and Lance gave you!„ Entrapta exclaimed. „ They never even imagined that it could be the work

of the First Ones...„ she frowned and began to look at him. „ It doesn't look like an ancient artifact, it seems quite ordinary. „ she grabbed the sword from Kyle's hands with her hair and started looking at him with some disappointment. She began to examine it using various strange devices that she had with her since the wedding... Who takes such things to a wedding! Entrapta was a very unusual person, she reminded her a bit of Doctor Quin, but was much nicer.

„Exactly, you have no reason to suspect that there is anything wrong with him or me!„ he shouted, making a panicked face.

„You know that's not true, Kyle... „ said someone who her glasses couldn't recognize, so she started looking around and looked at the place where Eti was looking. There, a tall figure emerged from the darkness. She looked a bit like one of the clones, but she wasn't exactly one. She had more delicate facial features, a clearly visible nose, and her ears were not as wide, but slightly longer. She also had scars all over her body, they seemed to be fresh and resembled a broken vessel. She was dressed in the blue robes of the Sorcerer. She took a fighting stance, Eti reached for her rifle, Tirin Transformed one of her hands into a weapon, and Entrapta looked on in confusion. But Kyle looked at her as if he recognized her. He looked down as if he was ashamed.

„Who are you! You move and you die!„ the cat girl said glaring, aiming between the creature's eyes.

„This is... „ Kyle started, but the newcomer interrupted him.

„My name is Nightgale... Kyle and I met some time ago, and now we meet again... But you know me by the name Scarlet...”

Tirin and Entrapta Stared at her without understanding, they had never met Scarlet. She didn't get to know her well either. However, this creature did not resemble the red”haired girl at all...

„What happened to you...„ Kyle said quietly.

„She grew taller, paler, changed her hair color... „ Eti said. As if she was explaining something obvious, it seemed as if her girlfriend didn't really care about how much the other woman had changed...

„That's not the point. She's always been like this, Her scars... They're the same as hers... Tell me you didn't do it!„ Kyle called. He looked distraught... But the creature smiled very sadly.

„Yes! I performed the ritual. I did it to free her. Free my mother... Free Shadow Weaver...„ She said in a quiet voice.

„You are the daughter of Shadow Weaver! it's amazing. „ Entrapta shouted, beaming with excitement. „This woman's biology is as fascinating as Adora's. Her ability to manipulate magical energy by absorbing external sources is absolutely unique. If we could test her and recreate this ability, then... „ the inventor princess looked at Nightgale. „But who was your father...”

After this question there was silence as everyone guessed what the answer was. Daughter of Shadow Weaver was about to respond when the entire castle shook, and she felt as if someone was screaming.

„I guess let's deal with that first, and then we'll talk about other issues.„ said Eti, flattening her ears.

They all nodded in agreement and ran after Eti, who led them towards the source of the sound.

He was actually grateful to Scarlet, for that she was able to keep a secret. He knew that sooner or later she would want to use it against him, and for now he tried not to think about it. There was too much going on in his life for him to accept this Asorceress. He noticed that they were close to Shadow Weaver and he guessed the reasons, but he figured it was better for them to take care of themselves rather than try to blackmail him. Or worse yet, study him... He was afraid that the Dark Sorceress will want to use his

power just like she wanted to do with Adora... But apparently Scarlet behaved honorably and remained silent... Although, as he just found out, she wasn't Scarlet at all, but a completely different person... Nighgale... He hoped she didn't hurt the former cadet... He didn't know the old Scarlet very well, but he didn't like it when others got hurt.

He was also glad that the screams distracted everyone from him and his secrets... Given the current situation, it was even good that he met Eti and Rosie, because whatever was waiting there, maybe they could handle it without having to summon that guy... Although he also missed that power and might a bit...

Eti was fast, maybe not as fast as Catra, although she couldn't help herself when running with her hands, but it was a miracle they could keep up. The hardest part was Nightgale, who looked exhausted. He didn't ask her how she managed to free Shadow Weaver, but judging by the scars that appeared on her body, the price was too high...

They reached a huge room, he had not even expected that there could be such large chambers in this castle. In the semi-darkness he could see neither the ceiling nor the ceiling. Their footsteps echoed in the huge hall.

„Hi! Is anyone here! „ Eti shouted, and everyone, except Rosie, jumped at the sound of her words .

„Did you have to tell everyone we were here?„ said the woman he knew as Scarlet ·

„We made so much noise when we ran here that everyone knew we were coming.” the cat girl replied to the sorceress. She snorted and started looking around. Eti And probably Nightgale could see in the dark, he also suspected that this petite girl in a strange suit had some device that allowed her to see in the dark, and Entrapta put on a strange mask that made her look like an insect, and she started looking around the whole room, a if she could see everything perfectly. . Probably, apart from the deaf girl, and even

in her case he wasn't sure, he was the only one who couldn't see anything this darknes. He shuddered, he never liked the dark. Then he heard crying coming from all over the room. They huddled together, trying to look as menacing as possible... Eti and Nightgala certainly looked menacing, and the rest... well, at least they tried ... Crying was the only sound that could be heard here, and it was so quiet that they could even hear their own beats. hearts. Probably at that moment Eti relaxed, she apparently saw something that calmed her down. It helped him, so he was also calmer. Cut to the center of the room where they saw a huge metal machine. It resembled a combination of a snake and an insect. The elongated lower part was curled into a ball, while it resembled a praying mantis due to its four sword-like limbs. The most disturbing thing was the head. It seemed to have a human face, with four crystal eyes. A small, translucent figure was kneeling next to her, and only after a moment he recognized her. He had seen her once in these undergrounds in Ruined City, and then their lives were saved by this strange Frosta's creature... Now they couldn't count on hers help... However, he noticed that Eti and Rosie didn't look scared, or rather saddened, unlike Nightgale. The Sorceress spread her legs wide in a fighting position. Entrapta didn't pay much attention to the machine she approached, fearing nothing at all..

„Hello Heart Gift.„ Eti said with sadness in her voice. „So you already know..."

The holographical figure slowly stood and looked up at them, as if she had just seen them.

„Did you know? Did you know then that they were dead, that I was alone... „ Said the Holographic Person, her girlish voice breaking.

„I guess we suspected it, but we didn't fully understand everything yet. And besides... We didn't know how to tell you about it.„ Rosie explained. The white-haired girl looked as if she was to blame for what happened to this person.

„It's unfair! They were good... Noble... Full of love... I loved them... They were my mothers... What will I do now... I don't want to be alone anymore.. „ Heart Gift curled up into a ball and started crying again. Entrapta, who had previously only paid attention to the machine, turned to the hologram and asked.

„What happened? When were they? I'm sorry if I'm asking, but this is our first time...„ said the woman with purple hair.

Heart Gift She raised her head and looked towards her.

„My mothers... Mara and Light Hope...„ When these names were mentioned, the inventor's eyes widened. He himself recognized only the first of these names. This was the name of the previous She-Ra. The latter also seemed familiar. However, he was unable to remember who it belonged to.

„I'm so sorry...„ said the former mistress of this castle, and tried to hug Heart Gift, but of course it was impossible, so she just knelt down next to her.

„And what!” The holographic being said loudly and got to its feet. „They are dead! Because of her! She took the first one's sword and forced the second one to delete itself. She killed her!„ the entire castle trembled from the last words. Everyone jumped away from her except for one. The Inventor Princess continued to kneel by the Heart Gift and said.

„I also lost my parents when I was very young... I was left alone in this castle... At first I didn't know what was happening, only then I understood the truth... I never coped well with what I felt... I was angry and sad. Angry at them for abandoning me and at the world for taking them away from me. I was lonely, at first because no one visited me... Then I realized that I was different from other people and that it was hard for others to deal with me... I can be difficult and sometimes I forget that other people are also important... I focused on technology and science. I always liked them because they allowed me to distance myself from my problems. The laws of science have always been clear

and unchanging. I have always understood the behavior of the machines I built, but it was different with humans... They were a mystery that I couldn't penetrate. I finally found friends who accepted me as I am... I know that it will be hard for you now, that you will suffer, that you will be angry at everyone and everything. These emotions eventually try to get weaker, but they will never completely disappear. Always throw away more of this sadness and sense of loss. Something bad is going to happen to you, but don't let it overwhelm you or take control of you. I know it's difficult and that it seems impossible to you now, but sooner or later the pain will ease, although it will never go away... But you will meet someone who will make you see that life is not a dark abyss... „ said the inventor... Heart Gift looked at her, she tilted her head and said.

„How did your parents die...„ said the AI and looked the inventor straight in the eye. Entrapta looked down

„I don't know... I never thought about it... I guess I didn't want to know... I guess I was afraid... it doesn't matter because I would like to ask... „ The inventor princess tried to change the subject, but Heart Gift walked up to her and said.

„Now you can find out. I guess you should know the truth too.„ she tilted her head as if she was listening and said.

„Argentium Eye and Joyfull Spark thirty years ago organized a research expedition from Castle Crypto in order to find the source of the power emanating from the planet's deeps. They were to confirm the existence of the Starstone and investigate its connection to the planet's energy grid. They constructed a vehicle capable of traveling through the Dryl tunnels to reach the planet's deeps... However, they were later captured by the planetary defense systems and interrogated by the Savior security system. Unfortunately, several weeks of intense interrogation failed to extract any information until they began to recall visions of their daughter being tortured... Then they broke and revealed everything about their mission and Etheria. During further interrogation, one of the captured people was irreversibly mentally

damaged. The condition of the second one was not much better, and her body stopped functioning, so she underwent a conservation procedure and was handed over to the Curators. – Heart Gift in a alien-sounding voice and looked at Entrapta expectantly. The inventor princess cringed and turned pale. The Holographic Person's words shocked her greatly.

„Why are you telling her this? And in such a heartless way! „ Rosie exclaimed, glaring at Heart Gift, but the AI turned her head to the side and said.

„I told her the truth. She seems to like to know everything, so now she found out what happened to her family... It hurt as much as it hurt me when I found out that my mothers were murdered.” she said in a flat voice. Meanwhile, Eti started walking around her, looking at the machine. She touched it with her metal hand and flattened her cat ears. The holographic being turned to her abruptly and called out.

„Leave it!” he heard anger and fear in her voice. However, the cat girl ignored her and spoke in a strangely calm voice.

„Is that why you came here? It has to do with this machine, right?” she turned and looked at Entrapta. “Could you take a look at her?” she asked her. To his surprise, the inventor princess came out of her trance and looked at her and nodded and then she walked over to the machine and started looking at it.

„I saw the remains of other machines built by the First Ones. They were the ones destroyed in the Crystal Castle by Adora and Catra... They looked different from the Guardian who almost... killed She-Ra... Those were probably created on the fly by Light Hope, those spiders were probably similar to these the mosquitoes that Catra was fighting in the City of Elders Things. I couldn't check it out because we were all going home, but I'll go back there someday...”

Heart Gift She nodded and said.

„These machines were printed by the Cornucopia Cauldron, so it was decided that they should not be too complicated, in case... one of the AIs did not function properly... But this is something else. He was called the Inquisitor... They were to be triggered if the planet's governing council seceded or otherwise rebelled. Unfortunately, they were too independent and had to be used in moderation. They often imposed punishment at their own discretion and were ruthless, sometimes they even took power over rebellious planets and it was difficult to force them to give it up... Originally the supreme council agreed to it, but then she became more and more worried... They didn't want to risk that one of them will take control of a planet equipped with a Heart of Etheria defense system. Only at the end one of them was launched. But it was too late and the entire planet was lost, then there were no records. „ Heart Gift finished speaking in that smoky voice, and then she smiled darkly. „ They will understand what was done to me and bring justice to those who murdered them.

„Does this mean that they have an independent AI? „ Entrapta asked, and Eti began to examine the bot more closely. She touched it with a strange hand, as if she sensed something that was troubling her.

„The achievement of a certain primitive civilization from Golarion was used…... They have their own spirit, coming from the Axis, instinctively following the law... Why am I telling you all this, you have no authority...„ She began to look at her more carefully.

„Now you decide who has the authority.„ Eti said and jumped in. They look as creepy as a machine. „Now no one controls you... There are no First Ones left, except for Adora.„ as she said this, he saw out of the corner of his eye that the woman he once knew as Scarlet was smiling darkly. Heart Gift looked at her in disbelief.

„The empire could not fall... It is eternal, glorious, wonderful... it was... „ she said in a trembling, frightened voice, but Eti shrugged and replied.

„But it's gone and that's it. I guess that's how it is with Empires...„ Eti's voice was as dispassionate as always. „By the way, does he have a hatch or something to get in?”

Heart Gift blinked just like a living being and said in genuine surprise.

„Why do you need this knowledge?”

„To start it, because you obviously can't, because you would have done it a long time ago. said the cat girl. kicking the bot. Trin jumped at the sound of each blow, and Rosie winced at her girlfriend's actions.

„And you're not going to stop me?„ the AI asked, her voice becoming more and more confused. The cat girl stopped for a moment, as if she had to think about her answer.

„I guess I should, but I don't feel like it. However, I would like to have such a machine for myself. I need it. she finally replied.

„What do you need it for? „ Rosie asked. I guess she was worried about the cat girl's behavior.

„To many things... For example, to kill my father and save my sister.„ She said in a quiet voice. Meanwhile, Entrapta was examining the machine with a multitude of instruments that she apparently kept in her pocket at all times. Heart Gift She looked at Eti with a mixture of disbelief and horror.

„Why do you want to hurt your father?„ asked the shocked AI.

„Because he's a piece of shit. Millions have died because of him, and even more will die if no one stops him. But not only because of this. He created me to manipulate my sister.„ the scout turned to Heart Gift. Standing around the bot's world, like a hunter on a fallen beast. „As you can see, you're not the only one with family problems... If you think about it, everyone here is an orphan who only has friends. Our parents are either dead or better if they were deadFor the first time in his life, he saw a smile appear on

Eti's face, a strange, sad smile. It was so painful and bitter that it hurt to look at him. The holographic being looked around and looked at them.

„I don't understand. What happened to your families?„ She asked, increasingly lost.

„My father was the commandant of the Jadehell labor camp. He, in the name of the glory of the Star Empire and the Destiny of the Human Species, tortured thousands of people. My mother couldn't stand all this and ran away with me to the poisonous jungle and... „ said Tirin and pointed to her eyes and hair. „I became this... Then for years I watched the prisoners suffer, until one day I helped the rebels by killing hundreds of my compatriots. My father would also have died then, but he had been dead for a long time... „ she said. This girl's voice was surprisingly hard and full of Anger. He sighed and started telling the story himself.

„I didn't know my family and to be honest, until recently I didn't care about it at all. I was just an orphan like everyone else... Almost all my friends.„ he looked significantly at Nightgale, who smiled sourly. „The one person who was like a mother was a woman who absolutely terrified me and for whom I was just one of many children she was willing to send to their deaths if it was worth it.„ he said with strength and anger that he did not suspect in himself. He always accepted everything without objection, He accepted that he was the weakest of the group to which he belonged. But now, when he thought about what had been done to them in the Fright Zone... And perhaps about what had happened earlier, that he had been sent here without any consideration for whether he would survive... He felt anger rising in his heart. He had never understood so well what Lonnie was fighting for. His girlfriend was fighting to show everyone that they could no longer be manipulated... That I would no longer be anyone's tool But he still remained one, he just didn't know yet who were in charge and what their intentions were... Although he already guessed.

„My father banished me... He condemned me to loneliness. „ Nightgale said... Entrapta leaned over her datapad and began to whisper to herself. As if you wanted to drown out the young sorceress' words, she smiled maliciously and continued. „I met my mother recently, and we immediately had to separate. To help her, I performed a ritual that warped my soul. I am now what you see. „ She laughed briefly and bitterly. Rosie hesitated before she spoke.

„I don't know my family, and now I'm not even sure if I ever had one. But I found a new family.„ She looked at the cat girl. „ I don't really know who I am, I'm not sure of anything anymore, but I know that I won't be lonely anymore. I have no idea where I came from. „ she gave him a short look. He didn't quite understand what she meant, or he didn't want to understand...„ However, who I become depends only on me. She smiled and for a moment he felt as if he was glowing. Heart Gift She looked through them, confused, overwhelmed by all these confessions. Finally Entrapta Said

„Your mother's were Mara and Light Hope, right? I don't know much about Mara except what was in the few messages she left for us... I saw and examined them many times, because they were a very valuable source of knowledge. I know almost nothing about your other mother, only what Adora told me...„ Inventor Princess looked up at her datapad and continued. „I know that she and Mara loved each other very much, but then she was reprogrammed by their superiors, she wanted to hurt your second mother... I guess she succeeded, and then she wanted to start the Heart... Then we would all die, including you... She wasn't evil , only her mind was rebuilt, at the end she remembered Who she was and what she once felt. Adora told me this.”

Now SI sat down on the floor and hugged her knees. She started crying spasmodically. At the sight, he felt his heart being torn apart.

„I don't want to be alone. It all hurts so much, and I am alone, alone in the world.„ She spoke through tears as if she were an

ordinary biological girl. Tirin walked up to her and knelt down.

„You're not alone. We are here with you. We won't replace your mothers... But we can be your friends, right?„ The girl in the bionic suit looked at the others questioningly. Rosie walked up to her and smiled. The purple haired woman did the same, he too walked up to the artificial intelligence and gave her a comforting smile since he obviously couldn't hug her. With some hesitation, Nightgale approached her and joined the others in the comfort of the ancient holographic being. Eti came at the end, jumping off this strange machine, but she slipped and tripped. She touched the area between the machine's eyes, and they began to glow.

„I assure you it was planned! „ Said the cat girl.

Rosie wasn't surprised by this turn of events. In all the movies she had watched, when the characters found some old machine, it seemed to work one way or another, and with their luck, it was almost certain that it would happen. the problem was that when such a Droid woke up, it usually wanted to kill the heroes. Something told her that this ancient machine would not be pleased with their presence. The droid straightened up and began to look with its glowing eyes.

„There has been an Awakening. senses rebels throughout the castle, the planetary interface has been deactivated, probably the rebels have taken control of the research facility. Perhaps the entire defense installation fell into their hands. It will be necessary to activate a purification mode that will lead to the extermination of life on this planet. We were forced to do this by the tardiness and excessive forbearance of the members of the highest council. There would be no need to go to such drastic measures if we were listened to and strict control combined with full conditioning was introduced. It will be necessary to establish contact with the remaining guards.„ he said and started looking at them.

"I think we've gotten ourselves into trouble…" she said and took a step back as the robot's disturbingly piercing gaze fell on her, but then Entrapta ran to the machine and jumped up in a fit of excitement.

„Oh, what a wonderful combination of technology and magic!„ She clapped her hair and hands. „Before you do the terrible things you talked about, will you let me examine you? You'll probably be destroyed soon anyway, and examining the remains is much less effective. „ She looked at the colossal machine with pleading in her eyes. Then Heart Gift stood in front of them and Shouted.

„I forbid you to do this! You cannot oppose me, because I am... Because I was created by Light Hope, the planetary interface of this planet, and after she... deactivated herself, I took over. I can connect to most Etherias systems....„ she seemed absolutely confident, but this huge machine started laughing... Surely it wasn't so bad if he could laugh? This meant that he had some feeling of being a being with a soul.

„It doesn't work that way. You are not a princess, you cannot inherit the function... You shouldn't be conscious at all. This was not approved!" everyone stepped back after his last words, she felt him shout. "You will also be removed… The rogue AI cannot be allowed." Then he turned and looked at Eti.

„And this is interesting... I sense the Work of enemies... Masters whose usefulness has ended, who out of pure jealousy forbade us to follow the path that was our destiny. However, you are not one of them, on this hand are the traces of our Technomagic Masters. Has anyone managed to recreate the bodies of the Knights Eternals!? But this is just one part of your body. Your genes point to something much more interesting. No one expected that any of these abominations would still survive... „ he said, looking closely at Eti, who seemed to be bored with his short speech, but she felt outraged.

„You won't call my girlfriend an abomination!„ She said, approaching the machine which directed its incredibly piercing

gaze straight at her.

„What are you doing on the side of the rebels? You were supposed to be absolutely loyal, your minds were supposed to be incapable of Defying your creators... „ he said and then she felt a cold sweat break out on her. Since that fight two days ago, she had tried to ignore the suspicions that had been forming in her mind. She was happy with Eti and could not think about all this She had almost managed to forget that she had lost her memory for a moment, but at the same time she was still aware that something was controlling her body. As if it had been stolen and then used to do something terrible… But now her suspicions were confirmed. Tirin and Entrapta looked at her and she felt like cringing.

„It's very nice what you're saying, but after thinking about it, I think it's just bullshit. Step away from him.„ the cat girl interjected and everyone did as she said and then Eti pulled out the detonator and pressed the button.. She felt a shock as the explosives her girlfriend had previously installed in the droid exploded. When did Eti manage to install them? Was it while they were talking to Heart Gift, or maybe earlier? The explosion caused the inquisitor to be thrown back, but unfortunately he got up almost immediately and looked towards them..

„Well, it couldn't have ended any other way.„ He said and jumped towards them, they jumped away from the colossal machine. She flashed with light, ready to fight... Power filled her body, she jumped towards the droid and punched him. Anyone else would have broken their arm at that moment, but she didn't feel even the slightest pain The metal at the point of impact bent slightly, but she didn't do anything else. What else could she expect, attacking an ancient droid with her bare fists. During this time, Eti fired her rifle several times, but with even more poor results than when she used her hands. Tirin transformed one of her arms into some sort of blaster that spat acid. It left the metal giant's body on the surface, but nothing else. Entrapta surprisingly skillfully jumped away from her opponent and started typing something on her datapad. And Kyle grabbed his sword with both hands and

struck. Surprising everyone, especially the blond-haired boy, it left a long scar in the place she had cut, as if the metal wasn't harder than paper. Heart Gift looked at herself throughout the fight, with terror on her face, unable to do anything. Nightgale uttered a spell and suddenly a dozen or so mirror images of the sorcerer appeared. For the next few moments, there was an exchange of blows between their small group and the formation of the first ones. They were not successful…

„We should probably get out of here! Nightgale exclaimed.

„If you don't deactivate it quickly, it will activate the other machines and the cleansing process will begin! „ Heart Gift exclaimed.

„What other machines?„ Kyle shouted.

„Oh, those like that!„ Eti pointed to several more bots that began to arrive from the darkness. They were oblong, even snake-like, resembling flying millipedes.. Their limbs were equipped with long blades or small cannons. One of them jumped towards Eti. In fear, she rushed towards it and grabbed the droid by its tail, throwing it over its head and slamming it to the floor, smashing it into pieces.

„If we need to bring in a new refrigerator, you will do it.„ Eti said, looking at her proudly. She was proud of her! It's so wonderful! Overcome with so much joy, she didn't even notice when another droid started shooting at her. It threw long metal spikes. Most of them missed her, but one hit her foot, pinning her to the ground. She screamed, although of course she couldn't hear it. She didn't even feel pain, and was immobilized. The droid was preparing for another attack, but Eti covered her. Suddenly, the cat girl's arm began to transform. it became a long and curved crescent-shaped blade, somewhat resembling a scythe. Eti looked at her weapon in surprise, and then enraged the machine, cutting it in half. The navigator and the blond-haired boy knocked down several more while the inventor continued typing, avoiding the blows. The Inquisitor focused on the sorcerer, destroying more of her mirror images.

„I think I managed to hack it... It's great! Perhaps I can do this with other First One’s machines!!” Entrapta exclaimed , seeming to be filled with pure joy.

„Could you take care of the ones trying to kill us first? Nightgale exclaimed.

„Oh yes, I almost forgot.„ she said, and suddenly all the Droids around started twisting and then started dancing around... Except the referee.

„You did quite well for such Uncivilized savages, at least... It was pleasant entertainment, I admit, but Etheria won't purify itself... I'm sorry this has to happen to you, but there's no other way.

And then suddenly the others began to writhe to the ground and contort their faces in pain, except for Eti, who staggered and then arched her body as if in ecstasy...

„Oh, this music...„ The cat girl told her, smiling.

“It's like the signal on the Beast Island, only much stronger and it... it causes suffering... „ The inventor groaned. Seeing that only she and Eti were ready to fight, she tightened her chest and lit up with an even brighter light. She felt they were overflowing with power. You felt like she could move boulders or crush them with her bare fists. So she jumped at Inquisitor, ready to smash him, and suddenly he looked at her , and she was immersed in blinding white light.

Everyone always accused him of being sensitive to pain. That he cried for no reason, while everyone else gritted their teeth and did their own thing. That's why he tried not to complain and not to show that it was difficult for him sometimes, how much effort he had to put into his achievements, no matter how poor they were. But now he was lying on the floor in pain like he had never felt before. His companions were either lying there like he was, or something even stranger was happening to them. Eti was

staggering as if she was drunk, and Rosie tried to fight back, she even flashed a blindingly bright light, and then she tried to jump at the inquisitor, but he suddenly looked at her and she stopped dead in her tracks.

„I could leave you here like this, or give you over to Savior for interrogation. But I think that you should suffer the same fate as most of the inhabitants of the planet... „ Said the ancient machine, and then strange gray goo started moving towards them, which reached one of the destroyed bots, which looked at it and dissolved it. He realized that the same would happen to all of them, and perhaps to the rest of the planet. Everything I know, everything he loved will turn into this gray goo. There will be nothing... Perhaps others will be able to stop this disaster, but his friends in the castle will not be able to escape, let alone those here. They weren't very close, although he liked most of them... He didn't want to die now or let them all die, so despite the terrible suffering, he gritted his teeth and stood up and reached for his sword.

„I have... I have this Power!„ He shouted, pulling his gun out in front of him. He felt a power wash over him, great and wonderful. He felt strong and powerful again. You can take it over your head and the gray goo begins to hiss and evaporate. The referee looked at him and said with confidence.

„And they did it anyway. Even though they were forbidden to do so, they used a fragment of the Golarion stone! This planet and everything associated with it was to be annihilated! I'll have to fix the others' mistakes.„ and the powerful Machine jumped towards him, but he was ready for it, he struck a powerful blow and cut off one of the arms, and then he chopped him again and again. He struck until the terrible machine fell apart. Finally, he struck the final blow and the machine fell to pieces. He stood over the remains, smiling triumphantly at his victory. He saved everyone…. his loved ones and new friends... Who were now staring at him with open mouths. Of course, apart from Nightgale, who knew everything, and Rosie, she had to walk towards him with a

strangely absent expression, but Eti put a hand on her shoulder and the deaf girl stopped suddenly and blinked.

„I... I can explain it all... I've been like this for some time, since I got this sword... „ he explained desperately and returned from his usual form, in which he felt weak and inept again. What a growing terror. He was afraid of what would happen next.

„Okay, now you're definitely my brother-in-law.„ Eti said and patted him on the shoulder.

„NO! Please! Don't tell anyone about this.„ He said, looking at the others pleadingly, and Eti shrugged.

„Okay, we won't tell anyone about it... I have the impression that we have to be very careful when talking about what happened here.„ she said thoughtfully, and Entrpta looked at her as if she had said something absolutely terrible...

„But... But we have another... Another... „ She protested, and when she was ready, the girl interrupted her.

„We don't know what and who we have... Now we have to think among ourselves what happened here... Where is Nightgale?„ The cat girl suddenly asked because it was the girl, looking around.

Nightgale, while everyone was focused on Kyle, decided to hide in the shadows and observe everything. Eti looked around for a moment, but she quickly gave up and was simply moved by disappointment.

„We'll talk more on the way... „ she said in that strange, dispassionate voice. Then Heart Gift came along.

„I searched part of this complex, there is no second inquisitor and all bots have been muted. I'm sorry I couldn't help, I guess I could use a new body, a material one... you know, Avatar.

„That would be an interesting idea, and you're a pretty girl, so maybe someone would be happy about it... „ She said, and Rosie looked at her sideways.

Then she felt a gentle touch on the back of her neck. You turned around and saw Dr. Moors.

„We have now witnessed extraordinary things, wonderful and unbelievable events, and what do you think? „ The brain in the top hat asked in a whisper, and she only raised an eyebrow in response.

„Take me to those you work with, I will be more useful to them than here.„ Said doctor, please. She nodded in response and then walked over to the others.

„Kyle, this may be our last conversation... And certainly the last time we're on the same side... Please tell Lonnie that she's a good leader and that I'm sorry things turned out this way.„ Then she looked at Entrapta „And you tell your husband that I will never forgive him for abandoning me...„ she said to the confused inventor. She was just about to hide in the darkness when a voice rang out from the remains of a battle.

„Sigma one has been destroyed... Warning sent to Saviorand Flagship Darkstar... Warning received...„ said the colossal Bot and fell silent, its eyes going dark.

Chapter End Notes

It took a long time to write this chapter and the next one may be delayed due to private problems.

The Fall of Kesler - Fight for life part one

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The mountain looked impressive. Although she obviously didn't have a good comparison. Most of the mountains on Atrax were wind”eroded bare rocks rising into the dark sky. Although of course she almost never left the Rift, there was no reason to do so. She was a city girl, and most of the tasks her father assigned her did not require her to go to the provinces. The mountain was bare, devoid of any vegetation, and its edges were so sharp that it felt like a dagger or a claw. She looked at a tourist leaflet and learned that ten thousand tourists visited this place every year until the tragic avalanche that killed fifty people... From then on, the place was closed to tourists until it was finally has been taken over by military intelligence, although only the last of course they didn't write it in the leaflet. Despite everything, she felt almost safe... Because how could one feel safe at all, on a planet attacked by the greatest scourge of the Galaxy? Then again, she was probably together with the most trained soldiers on the planet. She could only hope that Igzar wouldn't want to abandon her once she was no longer useful, and for now it didn't look like she wouldn't have something to do anytime soon. Igzar's subordinates even liked her, but if their boss orders them to kill her, or even throw her off the ship, they are unlikely to risk conflict with their commander... That's why she had to come up with something to make him want to cooperate with her... However, she already had an idea.

Despite the impending danger, Igzar ordered a halt. This surprised her, but she wasn't going to question the old tom's competence, no matter what he said, he certainly knew his job. So she

approached the commander of Shadows, who was watching his soldiers work on the rocks..

„What are you going to do after you leave this planet, on Atrax?„ Igzara asked, crossing her arms on her chest. Black Cat looked at her, narrowing his eyes.

„It's probably none of your business. Better take care of the kids instead of being interested in issues that do not concern you.„ He growled darkly and lit another cigar. He smoked like a dragon, they suspect that he simply replaced his lungs, so he didn't have to worry about getting sick. You smiled, she would have tried to seduce someone else, but from what she knew, like many Pahtra, he had no interest in these matters, so she decided to appeal to his common sense, or burning hatred.

„I have contacts.„ she said, tilting her head. "Having connections is one of the reasons I live.„ She said it truthfully... Her father only kept alive those daughters who were useful...

„I don't need your father's contacts ...„ he told her sharply.

„I would even say that you don't need my father at all.„ She replied warmly, sounding like she wouldn't be dying inside from fear.

„Really? It's very good of you to tell me about this." He smiled nastily at her.

„I would say quite the opposite... Because of who my father is working with, you two have become mortal enemies, right?"

He narrowed his eyes again and motioned for her to continue.

„As you probably guessed, not all of my sisters are happy that they are his property. By devils and demons, most of us hate him. You can be a bastard and a murderer, but your evil is so... natural. We are all his clones that he treats worse than things. We are something that can be sacrificed whenever it benefits us. Our souls, bodies and minds. If it weren't for the fear that one of them

would betray the others in order to prolong their life even a little, we would have been dancing in his blood a long time ago.„ she said with an anger she didn't know was hidden in her heart. When she started this conversation, she didn't think it would go in this direction. She was unaware of her hatred towards her father and creator. Until now, she had accepted the way he treated her, the way he treated everyone. But now they have a chance to change their lives to gain freedom they never dreamed of.

„I'll think about what you said. For now we have to survive, and that is not obvious at all.„ replied the black cat. She looked for a moment at what his soldiers were working on and asked.

„What exactly are you doing there?”

Igzar smiled slyly.

„They're installing explosives to blow up this slope and fill up the road.”

She frowned.

„But many creatures from the Swarm can fly.„ She asked again.”

„Only, we're not going to block their path...„ He said, laughing ominously...

„Are you talking about those who would like to get here... Those others who found out about this hidden landing site?„ She asked and the old cat nodded.

„We are predators, as we are soldiers, Rebels, Pahtra... And for predators, the greatest threat are Representatives of the same species. „ He chuckled, and it sounded like someone was sharpening a knife...

However, it turned out that Bina could prove her usefulness before leaving the planet. At the foot of the mountain there was a

spacious square ideal for parking several dozen vehicles, there was more than enough space for them... Even if you counted those who had arrived before them. She saw a dozen or so passenger cars, including two armored limousines and a few off-road vehicles... A dozen or so people in black suits, as soon as it saw them, it turned its weapons towards them. The Shadows did the same and it would probably end in bloodshed, mainly that of the first group, but she ran ahead of the rest of her comrades, although she was aware that it was not very wise, because she would be the first to get hit as soon as the shooting started.

„There is no reason to kill each other! We have worse enemies and we shouldn't fight among ourselves! We will all find a place on these ships, because they were prepared to transport the entire government with their families, secretaries and all that mess.„ she said and everyone from both groups looked at her. She didn't like it very much, but since she was the first to speak, she had to go with it. „I repeat, there is no point in us fighting."

At first glance, those they found there looked like gangsters. She saw that they had been here for some time, they had even set up a makeshift grill to roast meat on. Why they didn't go inside, but stayed here, exposed to the Swarm's attacks, but also to the rain that had started to fall for some time, she had no idea. Igzar stood a little behind her, close enough to give her his authority, far enough away for her to catch the first bullets if something went wrong. Vesk, slightly stooped but still powerfully built, emerged from among the gangsters .

„Good Afternoon, Bina.„ it said without a trace of accent.

„Good Afternoon, Father Scagerak.„ She said, bowing low, but not kneeling. There was one of the leaders of the Scane carter, who was involved in the biofuel trade in several autonomous districts in the East of the planet. He didn't see himself as a criminal, but as person who used brutal methods to get rid of competition and unfavorable politicians. Despite Being a Gangster, he was still a Vesk. He was ruthless and could be cruel, but he was also

reasonable and always kept his word... They could have done worse.

„I see you've found some new friends. Special friends, but also extremely dangerous... You know, one of my friends once kept a Skitterwander at home. Nasty Beasts, supposedly nice and friendly, but as soon as you turned around they were ready to drink all your juices.„ Vesk said and tapped his cane to emphasize your words. He didn't need it, except to beat his enemies... Igzar heard his words and laughed hoarsely.

„If this is a reference to me, I'm never nice or friendly.„ Said the old tom, a nasty smile appearing on his scarred muzzle.

„You know what, Scagerak? In our current situation, I guess we're all friends. Because we are all equally trying to survive during this invasion, even though we are attacked by an enemy that we cannot face.„ she tried to appeal to his Vescan sense of community and honor, as well as his desire to fight a more powerful opponent, although the latter was risky, because representatives of his species often sought glorious death at the hands of a worthy opponent. The cartel leader had just looked at them before asking a question.

„And how can I know that all this talk is just to lull my vigilance, to stab me in the back when my attention is diverted?”

She shrugged.

„It's simple, you don't have any. However, if Igzar was planning to kill you, he would have sent a team ahead with heavy weapons and so on, and killed you before you noticed anything. Let me remind you that this guy organized the assassination of Antares himself.„ She mentioned the turning point in the War of Tarak, although according to what she heard, the attack was carried out by Igzar's sister, but there was no point in dwelling on such details.

Father Scagerak looked at her for a moment, then sighed and said.

„I guess you're right... We wouldn't have emerged victorious from this fight, and since you didn't attack us in advance, I think it's good intentions... As much as people like us can have them. „ Vesk said. „And besides, we can't get in anyway.„ he pointed behind him, where there were huge metal gates.

„They didn't sell you the codes, did they? Well, i took them myself. It's the most sensible way, and I have a great hacker.„ he said, and she looked at him like he was crazy... *Poor Alatar*

Alatar and Itel looked through the maps, wondering if they were the last people to visit this reserve... It was a depressing thought. Everything they know will be lost, destroyed by the Swarm. He felt sad when he thought about it... Kesler was all going to be eaten... All those animals and everything, he was dead. He didn't watch many nature programs, but his sister liked them, at least when she was younger... It was always comforting that whatever happened, nature would survive and so on... And now, they would be one of the few to survive. As long as they survive, because that's not so certain. But for now they were safe, and he was in very pleasant company... Though he hoped the Elf wouldn't notice anything. That would be incredibly embarrassing... But luckily, Itel was focused on helping the Shadows navigate this national park. She was very happy to have some task, and she kept touching the handle of the knife that Igzar gave her. He could tell they were both tired, but they must have passed a certain point where they were tired for it to matter much. You could only hope that this would all end and he could rest. One way or another. He was quite religious, and believed that his sister and friends found refuge after death on other planes. He drank the energy fluid, because he wouldn't call it the drink that the soldiers gave him. Suddenly someone knocked on the hatch upstairs, then lifted the hatch and saw Bina's head.

„Hey Alatar, we need you down there. „ She said, smiling softer, and he had the impression that she was nervous. He nodded and followed the burgundy-haired woman.

It was raining outside. Fortunately, it was covered with scales and getting wet was not as severe for it as for other species. When he looked around, he saw not only soldiers around him, to whom he had become somewhat accustomed, but also sad and gloomy people in tracksuits and suits. He swallowed loudly as their eyes fell on Him. He had never been good in company, and once again he was on the verge of panic, especially since these people looked like gangsters or worse.

„Hello Alatar, our IT guy. He studied at Kessler City Technical University, but was expelled due to hacking of government servers.„ Bina said. Her eye didn't even twitch when she lied. He felt his heart start beating faster. He may have been the best in school, but it wasn't a big school, he had never even thought about hacking into government servers or anything like that. Of course, he was too young to be a student, but members of other species were rarely able to determine the age of Dragonkins. He grinned, trying to look as smart and confident as possible. The gangsters looked at him with curiosity, and fortunately, they usually looked a bit like him.

„So what should I do?„ he said, hoping that he sounded professional and didn't squeak.

„Come with me.„ Igzar said. Looking at him like that, he shuddered. This was probably the right reaction, because no one paid attention to it. An old cat and a woman with burgundy hair led him to a large armored door. They were at the foot of a mountain that cast its shadow. This place was such that it still gave him the creeps, even when he was surrounded by creepy guys like Shadows. He stood in front of the control panel, and Bina turned to him, smiling.

„Just enter these codes, trying to look as smart as possible.„ She patted his shoulder and he started doing what she asked him to

do. It would be easier if Igzar wasn't looking over his shoulder, looking like he wanted to hang his head over the fireplace. All the codes were accepted, so with a smile on his face he pressed the Open button. An error message appeared and he was typing on the small keyboard for a while.

“So you can't run these codes?” Pahtra growled and he shook his head.

„Anyone could do that, even... Bina.„ He bit his tongue at the last minute and didn't use the name of the mercenary leader... „The problem is that this door has no power... It just hasn't been used in a long time and the batteries are dead.”

„Well, we're in a mess... „ said Igzar

„It's not that bad if you have this type of batteries. „ he showed the Black Cat the specifications. „You just have to install it in a nearby power plant.”

„And where is she supposedly ?„ interrupted the leader of the Shadows of Tarak. He pointed him to the top of the mountain.

„Of course I'm going with you!„ Itel said, as if it was not up for discussion. Bina just sighed and waved her hand.

„I am not your mother or guardian. If you want, come with us as long as there is space.”

She had already written a breath to argue further, but when the woman agreed with her, she lost the plot for a moment.

„Well, then... „ she said, confused, and they got into the transporter together. She slowly began to hope that they would succeed, that they would escape... Before, she had just gone with the flow, She did what was necessary to survive, She didn't even think that there might be a future waiting for her. But now she saw that there was a chance. Maybe they could escape and... She

couldn't imagine what she would do next. Will she join the Shadows? Will she look for distant relatives? Apparently every Elf was related to everyone else in one way or another. From what she saw, it was some strange prejudice, like those jokes about Azlanti relationships with close relatives... However, she guessed that the Shadows would not accept her. They were picky, as far as she could tell, about recruits. They all seemed like seasoned veterans, many from Tarak, but not all, like the big Orc Wagar. They were true warriors, a rather random teenager from a planet consumed by the Swarm had no chance of becoming one of them. Maybe if she trains, she will be able to gain their approval. But did she really want to be a soldier for the rest of her life? But then again, did she have any choice? All her dreams were devoured, just as Kesler would soon be.

This Dragonkin was very happy when he found out she was going with them. In general, she had the impression that he was very interested in her. This was quite typical for those who saw the elf for the first time. There were so many myths and rumors surrounding her species that others expected Desna Doesn't Know What. She also saw Dragonkin for the first time, although she didn't stare at him like that... It was fair to say that until she was five, she didn't know that there were intelligent beings in the world that weren't Elves. When she saw a human woman first time, she cried when she saw her ears because she thought someone had cut them off. Another thing is that she recently noticed that boys and girls from school looked at her in the same way... And also somefrom the village, of course those who were not related to her. Did that mean that... No... No normal person would fall in love with someone at a time like this... They've probably never seen an Elf and that's it...

The way to the mountain led along a narrow road. More around the mountain. It was really Narrow, and when she looked out through the hath several times, she could see the abyss stretching around her. She wasn't afraid of heights, but the sight was still terrifying. If they turned just a little too sharply, they would fall into the abyss. This vehicle was so big and massive... Just like those old Veskarian trucks that were durable, but at the same

time clumsy and heavy, except that the armored transport was even clumsier and heavier... She wasn't sure if it was the best choice of transport. to the top of the mountain, she didn't decide. She could only hope he was tougher than he looked...

However, she had to admit that the views were beautiful. Until she was forced to leave her home and the beautiful forest where she grew up, she didn't understand how attached she was to such places. She loved nature and missed life in the forest, and now it was all lost. Everything she saw now would be devoured by the Swarm. All this beauty will become fodder for the monster that destroyed everything that was important to her. From what she had heard, Atrax was a dark planet, devoid of forests, where most people lived in a giant chasm, never seeing the open sky. She didn't want to live in a place like this, but she had nowhere to go. She sat down in the corner of the vehicle and hugged her knees and began to cry. She didn't like crying. She felt weak and vulnerable then. Everyone could see what she felt... Her family was encouraged to share feelings and talk about their problems, but while she was at the boarding school. Her peers often teased her not only because she was poor, but also because she was a strange, naive child who was, in fact, literally raised in the forest... For most of her stay at the boarding school, she had no friends, apart from her sister. although recently it had started to change due to growing up and things like that... but that was the past... Who would care about teenagers' problems when the world was dying... She felt stupid that she was crying, that those soldiers could see her breaking down. She always wanted to be strong and tough, but it turned out that she was soft and fragile.

„Here, it's a tissue... Save it, because there are few of them, and we need them when we go to the toilet.„ The red-haired girl handed her a tissue, smiling. This Dragonkin also approached her, smiling, this time with sadness. Very carefully, he put his paw on her shoulder and just said.

„ I...I know... „ and then she cried even more.

Bina had never been so high in her life. Yes, she had been to the top of the Jantar's Citadel several times, those were not pleasant memories, but compared to this place, that building was like a hill... If only she wasn't driving a terribly heavy and hardly agile armored personnel carrier, escaping from the destruction of the entire planet, she would have gladly admired the views. . There was this elven girl sitting by the hatch earlier, but she came back down and started crying. She wasn't surprised, after all, she lost her entire family. Her family… Well, when you have several hundred sisters, your relationships will always be complicated. She didn't want to disturb the girl, even though she knew she should go back there soon and comfort her too. But what could she say? She was in a much better situation than she was. She didn't lose anyone close to her, nor any valuable equipment, she even made some money playing cards, with a few Shadows... And with any luck, she would return home, although this home was... Well, you could say she never had a home. Jantar certainly wouldn't be happy that she was alive, but there was a chance he wouldn't kill her outright... And if she could convince Igzar to help... Everything would change... Damn, she could look to the future with hope, while these the kids lost everything. You felt guilty, which was something she rarely did, and in this one case it was completely senseless... She wasn't at fault in any way. She didn't summon the Swarm, she didn't kill their families... So why did she feel guilty? She couldn't give the right answer, so she sighed and went downstairs , and her place was taken by this huge Orc. She carefully approached the kids, who were now huddled together... She felt fear. She talked to her father, who had hundreds of daughters on his conscience, and Igzar, who was a terrorist known throughout the galaxy. She negotiated with gangsters and bandits who would blow her head off without hesitation. But she was no less afraid of these kids than of all these terrible people... So she knelt down and said.

„I won't say that I know how hard it is for you... Because I never had a real family, only sisters with whom... It doesn't matter... I'll try to help you... I have friends on Atrax and I can talk to people and I promise that you won't end up in an orphanage or in

refugee camp... I'll think of something. „ She had difficulty holding back the tears from her eyes. She hadn't intended to make that promise, but now she knew she would do anything to keep it. Even if she had to blackmail Igzar, even if she had to murder her father...

They finally reached the top of the structure. There was a parking lot here, and there were even some benches left. In short, they found themselves on a damn observation deck. While driving, she wondered why someone wanted to build a power plant nearly on the top of the mountain, until she saw windmills and doors hidden in the granite rock. Unfortunately, the fans were inactive and, according to their technician, it would take them too long to start them, so they still needed batteries. In addition to the windmills, there were also several transmitting antennas, so this place did not only serve as a power supply node. She didn't know much about warfare or anything like that, but even she wondered why someone would place the main power source at the very top of the mountain. When they went outside, she asked Alatar about it, and Dragonkin explained

„Because you have an emergency power source, at least from what that Control Panel showed. The entire base has an automated fusion reactor or something.”

„Are you sure if we will accidentally start glowing after staying there for a while?„ Igzar looked at the dragon teenager, who cringed under the gaze, and replied in a low voice.

„I'm just a computer nerd. I've never seen a real reactor up close, apart from one school trip, but back then I was playing Dungeon Fighter Pro Turbo all the time... I was good as Shalelu because she had a cool super combo... „ he was saying, but then Igzar gave him a look that made him drop sight.

„I guess we have no choice anyway, and besides, it's not his fault if he irradiates you because he wasn't the one who built the

fucking reactor!„ she screamed at him, honestly angry that the mean pahtra was shouting at Dragonkin. Igzar only snorted, but said nothing more. The orc turned the knob and opened the door, and they found themselves inside. Alatar began turning on the monitors and she, along with the Shadows Commander, began searching the small complex. They found the power plant quickly, and Wagar brought a battery, and after a while everything turned on. They started looking around. After a while, they realized that this place was not only a power plant and a radar station. Research facility and laboratory. There was a lot of equipment in a small warehouse, the dwarf named Virsek, who was Pahtra's second in command began to look at them and whistled several times. He was a pretty cool guy, but at first she wanted to punch him in the head when he offered her a sausage, and then you found out it was a real sausage...

„Here we have the retired AI, we can install it in our traansporter! „ He shouted happily while they were going through the rest of the equipment.

"What is this... „ She pointed to a large glowing stone covered with various markings. Igzar walked up to him and touched him. Then the stone flashed and the entire room was flooded with bright light. It blinded them for a moment, at first they only heard the new person, but they also felt it.

„Ha, it worked! I told everyone it would work, and they said it wouldn't work, but it did. That's because I am Ireanis Toromech called the Silver Flame!„ a woman's voice resounded throughout the complex, and she felt the strong smell of bad wine... When she regained her sight, she saw a dark-skinned Elf with silver hair. She wore the robes of a Sorceress and said with joy.

„Okay, now we're looking for Ashaq the Annihilator.„ She shouted and tried to run out of the room, but Igzar stopped her by grabbing her arm tightly.

„Who the fuck are you and what the hell are you doing here?"

„This is Ireanis Toromech called the silver flame, and I am here to kill Ashaq the Annihilator... Now please don't bother me because I have a lot of things to do. „ She tried to break free from Pahtra's grip, but he wouldn't let her go.

„But where did you come from, and you better answer briefly, because I'm not known for my patience with idiots.”

The elf blinked twice before speaking.

„Oh yes. Because you see, I went back in time to correct my past mistakes, and as you can see, I succeeded.”

„What time were you planning to go back to? „ she asked the Elf carefully, who thought for a moment before speaking.”

„Well, twenty years earlier, to the time when an expedition was sent from Nantambu to kill Mwangi's bane.„ She said as if she was explaining something very obvious.

„Mwangi?„ the dwarf scratched his head. „ And wasn't it on the lost Golarion?

„And why lost? Has anyone lost it? That would be terribly weird... „ Elf scratched her cheek and they stared at her with dropped jaws. „ I said something wrong?

She sighed and placed a hand on the Sorceress's shoulder.

„It's a long story and unfortunately we don't have time to tell it, Please sit somewhere to the side And breathe slowly, and we'll take care of everything... And there's no dragon nearby, And besides, There's no dragon nearby... This one here isn't a dragon only Dragonkin... „ She explained to the sorceress, who was nodding her head to the rhythm of her words with a monotonously stupid smile.

„ So I got drunk again and screwed up the spell. „ She started laughing spasmodically.

„ Hide this idiot somewhere, because your baby has something important to say. „ Said the black tom, signaling her to follow him

Alatar and the younger Pahtra stood near several monitors, staring at the image displayed on them.

„It does not look good. „ said Dragonkin, pointing to this map displayed on One of the monitors. At first glance, she thought it was some kind of storm cloud that she saw on one of the many local weather forecasts...

„ By devils and demons... „ She whispered to herself under her breath.

„Like they said, the Swarm is coming. „ Igzar muttered.„ We were going to get the fuck out of here anyway, so it doesn't matter to us.„ He said and was about to leave the room when his subordinate told him so.

„The problem is that the orbit is also blocked, at least in this place the entire area is under observation from orbit... We will not take off.„ When she said that, there was deathly silence. Everything was lost. There is no chance for them to save themselves. So much effort and all for nothing. They will die here, just like everyone else. She wanted to laugh, but at the same time she wanted to cry. She looked at everyone else and saw the same thing in their eyes... And then both betrayals and voices rang out from the speakers.

„Fortunately, the builders of this place have prepared for such an eventuality. A battery of rail cannons has been installed in the area, which can reach targets in orbit. They probably won't shoot down all the ships, but their fire will create a window through which you'll be able to escapeI'll tell you how to activate it, but in return I demand that you take me with you. I'm not going to die here, or worse, be trapped in this tomb for countless years.„ The voice sounded as if it belonged to an educated person, and at the same time it was artificial, as if mechanical.

„Who are you and why do you make demands?„ She called, and Igzar searched for hidden speakers with murder in his eyes.

„My name is Mr. Ilemshaw, or at least that's what you can call me. And I make demands because, like all living beings, I want to survive.„ The voice explained.

„If we can help you, that's fine, but you have to show us what you need to do to survive. „ She said, and old Pahtra glared at her for agreeing on his behalf, but she didn't care about his hurt pride now. He'll make a deal with this person if it means they can survive.

„I'm in the warehouse. My aquarium is mobile, although when it is disconnected from the main tank, it is quite cramped. I won't be able to communicate with you either, at least by voice, because fortunately I have telepathy. You must install me in a Witchlight-class ship to guide you through this window. Unfortunately, there is a slight problem, due to some negligence, the batteries have to be started manually. I'll tell you how, once you get into your vehicle... I know you came here in an armored personnel carrier because I have sensors that detect everything.

„Tell me, why, you son of a bitch, should I find you and start cutting you slowly into pieces?„ Igzar asked, smiling in his usual charming way.

„Of course you can try to do it, but I wouldn't advise it, and besides, I'm sure that my help as a pilot in your group of escapees will be more useful to you than you will enjoy torturing me.

„He's right, if we can get him packed quickly, we'll waste more time on these discussions, for what it's worth.„ She said, rubbing her face with her hands. Sometimes she had the impression that the old cat was less mature than the kids they had to travel with.

„Okay, but if you try any tricks...„ Igzar drawled.

Finding Mr. Ilemshaw wasn't difficult. His tank was located at the back of the warehouse, in a large room that looked like a combination of a laboratory and an aquarium. It was almost completely automated, he had control over all its functions. He was a strange three-eyed fish with tentacles. There was a small tank attached to the main aquarium, rather reminiscent of a Bathtub with Wheels. When an elven sorceress, claiming to be from the lost Golarion, saw him, she took a fighting stance and screamed.

"Algholith! „ But before she did something stupid, Igzar twisted her arms and growled.

„You do something like that again and I'll chop your hands off.„ He sounded serious to you that when he let her go, the sorceress crossed her arms on her chest and looked offended.

„In defense of this elf, I can only say that her reaction would be fully justified, in most cases, because from what I remember, he was not very nice...„ Everyone felt the voice of the creature from the aquarium in their heads. She didn't want to think about the exact meaning of his words. Despite Ireanis' gloomy look , they waited until she swam to the smaller aquarium before heading to her vehicle.

„Well, let me explain to you now, the orbital defense system can be launched from the control station located... At the very top of this mountain..."

Chapter End Notes

The fight will start in the next chapter

The Fall of Kesler - Fight for life, part two.

„Are you sure you can climb?„ Bina asked her, looking at her uncertainly.

„Of course, I climbed many times.„ she said, not actually lying, because she often climbed, but only trees. But climbing a mountain shouldn't be that much harder, right?

„I'll help.„ Said the red-haired girl, she thought her name was Lilka. „I once knew a girl named Lilka, she could climb because she went with her uncle to the mountains nearby. She climbed a lot. She was great at it.„ she said with great confidence. There was a short silence as no one knew what to answer. Bina finally cleared her throat and spoke.

„We have to hurry, because Alatar says the swarm will be here in little more than two hours.„ Bina looked at Dragonkin and added. „Let Lilka help you put on the harness.„ Burgundy-haired woman pointed to the red-haired girl. Itel had the impression that the dragonkin felt relieved and sad at the same time... He really was strange.

They started climbing. The three of them were walking, along with Bina, Igzar and that big orc Wagar, who had to help Alatar climb because the nerd was not fit enough to climb. At least not to the top of mountain. She felt a little sorry for the mighty warrior, because no matter what, Dragonkin was quite heavy, and he would almost have to carry it up the mountain.

Eventually they started climbing, and it went surprisingly well. Igzar was doing quite well for someone his age. Bina, much younger than him, had MUCH bigger problems She and Lilka were doing the best and would come forward. To their surprise, Alatar did quite well, especially thanks to his long and sharp claws, and sometimes he helped himself with his wings. There was no great

wind here, the rain stopped falling, and it wasn't even humid this high. Actually, the weather was great and if it weren't for what was coming, it would have been a perfect time to rest... They reached the top in record time. At the top there were more antennas and a small house. They suspected that the original crew got there either via a nanite ladder, an anti-gravity ladder, or simply some kind of flying vehicle. The building was almost invisible from below. The interior was practically unfurnished, there was only a computer and two chairs. Under any other circumstances, she would have wondered how the people who worked here spent their time, but now she didn't have time for that. They had all the access cards, so starting the computers was not difficult. Alatar quickly penetrated the defense systems, and in less than fifteen minutes the anti-orbital artillery was activated. The entire mountain range shook , and they saw huge magnetic cannons emerging from the nearby mountain slopes.

„When should you set the fire to start?„ Dragonkin looked at Old Pahtra, and he thought for a moment before answering.

„Two hours. When the guns start firing, counter-fire from orbit will probably begin. Then it will all be fucked up.”

The Dragonkin nodded, and they began to prepare to descend, but then they saw something on the horizon. At first she thought they were storm clouds, but then she realized. It was a giant cloud of Swarm beings. They weren't coming directly at them, but there were still so many of them that even if only a small part got detached... Then they saw that from the other side of the horizon, something was flying into that cloud.

„Get down!„ Igzar shouted and everyone rushed to the ground. Unfortunately, the dragon nerd was different from the rest. The mountains shook again and she felt the heat drop. When she looked up, she saw a Nuclear Mushroom growing in the distance. Alatar covered one eye.

„ I think I lost my sight in it... „ He said, his voice sounding embarrassed. It was so ridiculous to be ashamed of having gone

blind because of a nuclear explosion.

„It's a blessing in disguise that we are not threatened by radioactive fallout, because we will already be far away when the cloud settles.„ Igzar said and without waiting for anything they went downstairs as quickly as possible.

The dwarf, whose name was Virsek, was just finishing tinkering with their transporter.

„Well, I managed to install an AI on him! I don't believe they are unstable. They are simply not understood!„ He explained while painting eyes on their transporter. Ireanis looked at the vehicle with interest.

„What is AI?„ the sorceress asked and knocked on front vehicle.

„You could say it's like a ghost in the machine.„ Alatar explained, straightening the bandage on his face. He was still blind in one eye, and although he didn't complain, everyone could see that he was in a lot of pain.

„Ah! It's like the automatons from the fallen Jistka Empire, only portable and on wheels! And by the way, I think your volcano erupted! „ exclaimed the sorceress, pointing to a cloud floating in the distance. They didn't even want to explain to her what it was.

„That's nice, but how will it help us?„ Bina asked, looking at the dwarf suspiciously.

„Thanks to him, it will be easier for us to disappear from this damned mountain. It has space analysis system and can handle even the most uncertain roads!”

„It's great? But there is no time to waste, everyone get in!„ the woman with burgundy hair shouted and they did as she ordered. As they entered, she heard Bina stop next to Alatar and speak in a low voice.

„Listen, when this is all over, we'll get you a great cybernetic eye, or a new live one, if you prefer!„ She had the impression that she heard and I would reproach my conscience louder Why did she blame herself? It wasn't her who dropped the bomb!

Dragonkin smiled kindly at the woman, and together they sat in the vehicle... After all, this Bina wasn't that bad. Maybe he will actually help them?

She was furious with herself for letting these kids down, even though she promised I would take care of them. Barely an hour or two after she made her promise, Alatar lost the sight in one eye. She let him be dragged to the very top of the mountain, even though someone else could have taken care of it. No one expected it would end like this, after all, who could have predicted that there would be a nuclear explosion nearby. You shouldn't blame yourself, because it wasn't her fault. She shouldn't feel responsible for these kids. They were not her family, although even with her own family she had terrible relations, to say the least. So why did she care about them? She was raised so that her own health was the most important thing for her, that you only need to take care of yourself. The only thing more important than hers was loyalty to her father. They had to obey above all else, nothing was more important than Jantar's will . Eventually, however, each of them understood that their father had no regard for them and wanted them dead. That's probably why he limited their lifespan, and that's why he decided they had to get rid of her... She couldn't be like him, she had to take care of these kids, even if she had to die. But what could she do to save them from bane?

They drove as fast as they could down the winding road. The engine roared and the whole machine bounced over bumps.

„Something's coming! „ Virsek shouted, pointing to the screen of a small radar located in the vehicle's cockpit.

„Not something, just Swarm bastards.„ Igzar said gloomily and after a while he added. „Kreiz , go upstairs and operate the cannon!„ he ordered the younger Pahtra, she nodded and then moved towards the hatch. Bina felt afraid, she had only seen Swarm monsters once before, but they were scary enough for all of them that she knew she should be afraid. The red-haired girl named Lilka clung tightly to this huge orc, but they both held their axes indifferently. She never thought that a girl in ponytails could look dangerous... Alatar put wings on her shoulders, and this green-haired Elf called Itel took out a knife. She looked at the screen that occupied the front of the vehicle's interior and instead of the glass, it showed a view of what was in front of them via a camera. For a moment there was no indication that anything dangerous had appeared, the road was empty, as it had been throughout their journey. And then suddenly, like a terrible rain, swarm creatures fell on the road. The first ones looked like the thing the kids killed near the gas station. One of them looked in their direction and seemed to want to cast some spell, but the speeding armored personnel carrier was unstoppable. They hit it with their armored hull, crushing it to pulp. Green-yellow ichor splattered all around as each component of the swarm was crushed beneath the wheels, they began to scream in joy as this was a true success. Suddenly, something hit the vehicle and with a scream, the younger Pahtra fell down. And then a creature with paws as heavy as hammers jumped in behind her and hit Viirsek , who was driving the vehicle . The dwarf fell down , unconscious , but probably alive. Wagar, with a battle scream, hit the monster in the head, chopping it in half. Surprisingly, the vehicle did not deviate from the road, but continued driving itself... This autopilot was really good... She only had a strange impression that loud laughter was coming from the speakers as the vehicle crushed the swarm components, and then Igzar stood behind the wheel and gave the order.

„Bina go upstairs to Cannon, Wagar you will protect her.„ Pahtra ordered.

„ I?„ she asked him in disbelief.

„I speak Azlantian? Yes you! You can shoot, better than the orcs. „ He glared at her, and not wanting to discuss anymore, she went upstairs. As soon as she poked her head out, she heard the loud flapping of hundreds of membranous wings, looked around and saw Swarm components flying towards them. She grabbed her cannon, a laser weapon with a shield on the sides, and began taking aim. The sighting system was quite good, or at least easy to use , so that anyone could use it, including her. She began to aim and shoot at the approaching enemies. Short pulses of light cut the monsters in half, but there were more and more of them, and she couldn't knock them down. Next to her was this huge orc Wagar, which made it very tight for them, the warrior was actually sitting on the roof, but she didn't complain because he was holding her. The vehicle checked so quickly that sometimes they were only centimeters away from falling into the abyss. She wondered if the better handling was due to that artificial intelligence system that helped the old cat steer. Once or twice one of the insectoids tried to land on the roof, but the Orc's ax cut them in half. Sometimes they were shot at, but fortunately the shield built around the gun stopped the bullets. She saw that they were very close to leaving the mountain and were almost saved, but then something huge jumped on the vehicle. A gigantic component of the swarm, almost as large as the vehicle itself, was dug into the spaceship with its claws. Its upper limbs were tipped with huge blades like great scythes, which were probably capable of cutting through armored plate. She tried to direct her cannon at him, but he was too close and she couldn't turn the weapon towards him. The monster took a powerful swing and tried to cut her down, but Wagar blocked the blow with his axe. Miraculously, the blade stopped the beast's slash, and then Igzar made a sharp turn, tilting the vehicle to the side, causing the insectoid to almost slide down. But he grabbed on with those powerful hooked limbs. Moreover, they were all now hanging on the edge of the abyss, and the insectoid was outweighed and if they didn't do something soon, they would fall. Then Itel pressed through the hatch and threw the blade of her knife into the monster's eye. He hissed and then fell down. As he fell, she shot him through with a cannon shot. Only later did she learn that it was the Thresher Lord, one of

the most terrible creatures fighting in the swarm. The vehicle regained its balance, and they were back on the road. At this point they had already arrived at the gates of the complex…. the fire from below had dispersed most of the swarm monsters, so they were safe, at least for the moment.

„And I am unarmed again. „ said the Elf quietly

There was a huge mess there, like it was Uncle Bob's birthday... She didn't remember any Uncle Bob! But in any case, there was a lot of confusion, people were running back and forth, undecided whether to enter in cars or bring various things in bags. The bugs didn't attack them. Wagar, with a little help from Bina, drove them all away… Although he was a real orc warrior, so if he wanted to, he could defeat ten times as many enemies but he probably didn't want to make others feel bad.. She felt safe, after all, they were almost gone, they just had to board the ship. Mr. Dwarf and Mrs. Pahtra will recover, a Alatar will have a new artificial eye implanted, which will be better than the real one. Many of the soldiers she saw had similar cybernetic things and looked happy. Maybe she'll get some implants someday? She helped everyone pack. There were many ships inside , just as they said. These gentlemen and ladies looked at them as if they were surprised that they were here. How absurd, Mr. Igzar wouldn't lie to anyone. He was so cool, a little scary, but he smashed so many bugs, he couldn't be bad. She had never seen many spaceships in her life, only a few when she visited a big city with her parents... She had never seen so many ships and so large. This strange Vesk in the suit with this big staff seemed to be very happy. When they entered and saw all the ships, he knocked with his staff and looked at Bina.

„I didn't think you would keep your word.„ He had a pretty nice voice for a Vesk.

„I didn't keep any of my words, I just opened the door, or rather our hacker opened it. They were here waiting for us. The proof of

my honesty will be that we won't fight for a place, even though there are enough places.„ She pointed to the vehicle and everyone nodded like smart people at university.

„Can we pack now? We're in a bit of a hurry, and I have to go to the toilet BEFORE the flight, like every real orc!„ she interjected because she really wanted to poop and she wanted to do it properly, the Orcish way. They looked at her, Bina coughed twice apologetically, as if she had said something strange, but the large lizard laughed and, showing all its fangs, said.

„At my age, everyone only thinks about when they will finally be able to go to the toilet. I agree with you, there's no point in talking, we have to get in quickly and get away from this fucking planet."

„It was an ugly word, and we orcs don't use such words. „ Veska looked at the two seriously, and Bina hid her face in her hands. Did she say something strange?

„ Okay, let's get ready and pack." said Igzar and pointed to the aquarium. „He said there was a ship especially for him."

„In fact, there is this small one here, at the very end of the hangar.„ Mr. Fish said in their heads. Others usually didn't like it much, but it didn't bother her at all. It was a bit weird, but also quite funny. They all looked at the ship at the end, which was tiny, only slightly larger than their transporter. When they opened the side hatch, it turned out that there was only enough space inside to fit the aquarium with their new friend. This was indeed a ship especially for him. The aquarium drove itself inside, because I know it could drive itself, and then various cables and other things started to attach to it.

„Now you can leave me, I will take care of everything myself. You have to start the procedure, he was taking off, it's timed to coincide with the anti-orbital fire, so you better hurry, especially since we'll have another company soon

They did as he suggested and began selecting ships. Mr. Virsek , who had already woken up but had a terrible headache, chose a large ship that looked a bit like a box for them.

„It may not be the fastest, but it is well armored, maneuverable and has good jamming systems. This is great dwarven work!. He said, rubbing his head where he was hit. Together they got inside, where it was full of dust, no one had cleaned it for a long time, it was just a shame! They quickly started distributing them all over the ship. She quickly went to the toilet and did what was needed, they even had paper! Then she returned to the entrance and was disturbed to see that Wagar was nowhere to be found!

"They will guard the gate until it can be closed, and then he ran towards us. „ Igzar said to Bina in a gloomy voice. Without asking anyone's permission, she baked outside and ran to the gate. There was Wagar and some Vesks who looked really menacing, almost like orcs!

„Wagar! I am here to fight with you! „ she said with the confidence of a true orc warrior! Wagar turned towards her and looked at her in surprise.

„But what are you doing here?" he asked in a surprised voice.

„Well, I'm helping you fight the Bugs! I'am good at it!"

Wagar looked at her strangely, as if he was proud of her and worried about her at the same time. He was about to say something when she suddenly heard claws scratching and hissing, and then she saw monsters running towards them. At first she felt fear, so great that she couldn't move, but then she grabbed her ax and felt strength. She wasn't a weak little girl, but a terrible orc! She will defeat them all! They will never do anything to her again!

„We have company! You better close those gates quickly and someone will come for Lilka!„ Wagar shouted , throwing a powerful punch that chopped up one of the Bug, quite small one. She had seen such bugs before... She couldn't think about it! She

screamed and struck a blow, driving her small ax into another one. She didn't kill him, but she disabled him, and a nearby Vesk crushed him with his weapon. Then they pulled more, and her companions knocked them down. One by one.

„You know, Lilka, you don't have such a good weapon yet, so you can stand back and kill those who get through, okay? „ said Wagar . If he wasn't an orc, and orcs don't cheat, she would have had the impression that he didn't want her to fight with him. She did as he said, but she didn't fight anymore because no bugs got through. After a while, the Gate began to close and the orc and Vesks let out shouts of delight. Just in tim , because more and more bugs started attacking them, even one of the remaining warriors fell to the ground. He was bleeding heavily, but there was no one to help him. What's worse, the Gate will then stop closing. There was only a small opening left, one man's width apart, but they wanted to move on.

„These Gates Won't Close! Do something about it... „ The orc called over the communicator, and then he heard the answer. He made a very serious face and looked at her sadly.

„Remember, little one, you will always be a true Orc!„ He said to her and she felt like she saw apology and guilt in his eyes. She didn't understand what he meant, but then another wave of enemies began to move in. She was about to join the fight, but someone grabbed her from behind. She felt intense pain and her body went limp, and she felt something pulling her towards the ship, she tried to break free, but she couldn't move. She only saw Wagar knocking down one after the other, killing them as if without effort.

„ He sacrificed himself for you so that you could save yourself, so try not to waste it, kid. „ She heard Igzar's voice , the old cat dragged her on board...

His eye didn't hurt as much as he expected It mean, it hurt like hell, his mother always glared at him when he swore, but he was more afraid it would start leaking out of his eye socket or something like that. He wasn't even worried about losing his sight, he would eventually regain it one day, and from what he knew, cybernetic eyes were sometimes better than real ones . So he felt sad when he saw Bina taking it personally that he had been hurt. it wasn't her fault, she was very brave and helped them. She also managed to defeat that great bug, Although Itel also helped her... The Elf was wonderful to me, So he was afraid that his successes would seem so poor... Did he really think about the girls when they were fighting for their lives? His sister was right, not only was he a nerd, he was also an idiot.

He knew there was a fight going on outside. Actually, he should have been terrified, but somehow he didn't feel afraid anymore. He felt more excited. Finally this will all end, one way or another!

Igzar led Lilka inside, hanging limply over his shoulder.

„Where is Wagar?„ Bina asked.

„The door wouldn't close, so he stayed there to guard it.„ replied the mercenary commander.

„You have to go get him, we can't leave him!„ a woman with burgundy hair shouted.

„He sacrificed himself for us. Thanks to it, we will be able to fly away. Respect that and sit in the chair.„ He said sharply to Bina , who gave him an angry look but didn't say anything. He felt sorry for the Big Orc, as he may not have known too well, but he seemed like an okay guy.. What will they tell Lilka? They seemed to be friends.

However, he had no time for such thoughts because he felt that they were starting to take off. It crushed him into the seat for a moment, but then the gravity control kicked in. It was his first time flying in a spaceship, and he was actually excited. He always

wanted to visit other planets, and now that dream could come true. Of course, it would be much nicer if he didn't have to fight his way through the cordon of Swarm ships...

„The magnetic cannons have started firing!„ Said one of the soldiers sitting next to Igzar in the cockpit.

„They are effective, but are they enough?„ said old Pahtra , staring at the holographic representation of the navigation instruments. A few small blue dots represented her group, and countless red ones. They must have been Swarm ships. He swallowed saliva because it looked terrible. individual red dots were beginning to disappear, probably knocked down by the cannons he had fired. He felt satisfied. Maybe if they were ships belonging to normal beings, he would feel sorry, but they were Swarm monsters, They were nothing comparable to normal beings. They saw a gap in the enemy formation, one ship was heading there and giving bearings to the others. This strange fish”like creature was right after all, they would escape! They were very close, just a moment and they would escape. Several enemy ships fired at them and he felt their ship shake, but it wasn't even damaged badly enough to slow down. They would eventually get into orbit and then pass the cordon surrounding the planet. They were saved, at least for a while. He closed his eyes and sat in the chair for a while, numb. All the fear he had felt before was gone, as well as the excitement, sadness, everything was gone. Only a strange, blissful peace remained.

They flew for some time in sublight, no disturbed by no one, surrounded only outer space, a black void, as some people said. He knew they were still carrying safe because the Swarm fleet was waiting somewhere out there, but they could afford a little respite. Lilka was sitting in her chair, sniffling, she had recently learned about what happened to Wagar. Itel looked at everyone in disbelief, as if it was impossible to accept that they had survived. Igzar was smoking a cigar, and Bina was staring thoughtfully ahead, as if she was wondering something. There was silence. They should actually eat something now, but they weren't hungry. In fact, they didn't want anything, not even to rest. Was it like

that in the war? Eventually, however, the dwarf called them to show them something. He seemed concerned, so as soon as I returned, except for Lilka, everyone got to their feet and followed him to the navigator's room. There, an image In the nearest space was projected on a large hologram. They saw lots of ships. Several in the middle were blue, that is, belonging. There were also many grey ships, flying in two groups, one large, the other much smaller. And there were Swarm ships, lots of them. The ones they saw as they left recaptured were less than a fraction of the entire vast Flotilla. They were speechless when they saw so many ships..

„Won't they detect us?„ Bina asked, staring at the image.

„We have a good concealment field, and besides, there are too few of us and we are too far away to make it worth pursuing.„ said Virsek . They nodded at him, wondering if he was right. At some point, the swarm ships moved towards the main group of gray ships.

„These are civilian ships that are evacuating from the planet... It will be difficult to get them out. „ the dwarf explained, and then they saw the first, larger group scattering, while the second, closer one, flew in the opposite direction. The swarm ships gave chase after the fleeing ships. The smaller group moved further and further away, and suddenly another group of ships approached from where they were flying. They were initially blue, but the Dwarf typed something into the computer and they turned purple.

„The Fearless Armada is coming with its allies.„ Igzar said in a dark, angry voice.

„So these are Lord Admiral Antares's men ... They are coming to the rescue?„ Bina looked questioningly at the old cat, whose smile became very predatory.

„You'll see soon. „ said the old cat. The ships of the swarm rushed into the now scattered civilian ships, destroying them one by one.

They watched in silence as Thousands of people died. The Fearless Armada was in no hurry to help. They slowly surrounded the increasingly scattered swarm ships , which were constantly murdering those who escaped.

„What are they doing? Why don't they help the„ Itel cried with despair in her voice.

„Those civilian ships were used as bait. They were flown by ordinary civilians, those without important professions, contacts or assets. He will leave those sacrificed for Victory. The second group included important people, politicians, educated people, those who could not be evacuated earlier... Those who mattered.

„How can you sacrifice thousands of people just for Victory!„ the elf exclaimed with horror.

„Well, just like that.„ Igzar said, grinning. Indeed, as he had predicted, almost all of the civilian ships Were destroyed, but the Fearless Armada ships surrounded the Swarm ships and began to destroy them as easily as the civilian ones. Finally the invader fleet withdrew. The fearless Armada annihilated hundreds of Galactic Scourge ships…

„This is, dear kids, how heroes are born. Through trickery and sacrifice… preferably others.„ And the black cat began to laugh hoarsely.

Grim Covenant - Part One

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Calamity tried to act happy, but deep down she was furious. . She was furious with Shadow Weaver for basically getting away with her failures, her daughter's accident was no punishment at all. Life had taught her that everyone would rather see others suffer instead of them. People could claim that the lives of their loved ones were more important to them than their own, but it often turned out differently, especially in the case of someone like the Dark Sorceress.. On the other hand the girl had earned her own fate by going so far as to free Shadow Weaver, though she was impressed by what she had accomplished. Summoning the Devourer of Light was no small feat. Yes, she paid a price for it, but Mortals don't deserve that kind of power, at least for free. However, the girl was willing to pay the price, it showed that she was determined... It's just a pity that she made such a great sacrifice for someone so inept. The sorceress allowed herself to be captured for some absurd reason, and it was done by this monstrous freak of nature. Despite this, the agreement was still valid... She was even scolded for trying to kill the blonde idiot, although it wasn't she who tried to kill her, but the artificial intelligence, so there were no reasonable reasons to accuse her of it. Another thing is that, of course, she was right, after all, she was a usurper and a thief. She deserved to suffer for her sins. Well, she was a soft and delicate person, so perhaps the remorse of her twisted conscience would make her feel at least a little pain... Too bad she would have to suffer over something that happened to be a source of pride. Forcing an ancient AI to erase itself was quite funny, though of course, it seems that she did it by invoking the Illusion of Conscience that this being had.

However, as they say, as long as there is life, there is hope. This strange sorcerer that was near Nightgale… She had to admit that he was attractive, even more than attractive. She liked him much more than Klementine. To tell the truth, that girl was more irritating than attractive... She didn't regret what she had done with her at all, although she regretted very few things at all, but that was a characteristic of perfect beings. Everything she did was supposed to be great, but some people just put obstacles in her way. In this elf-like creature she sensed a kindred spirit, someone who saw the world as she did, though he was probably more experienced... She couldn't say the same about the rest of her siblings. Most of them weren't anything interesting. They were just creations of not very bright cultists who thought that by communing with the Great Outer God they would gain at least some power. Many of her Brothers and Sisters did not understand their Divine destiny, some even tried to imitate ordinary mortals. They pretended to be able to blend into their society, denying their true wonderful nature. In her opinion, these blasphemers deserved only a long and painful death... But none of that could be said about Evangeline. This person had renounced the morality that ordinary beings were guided by, and at the same time, in some strange way, followed it. She interpreted it in a strange, incomprehensible, and, according to many, perverted way. She had only met her ancient sister once, and that was one of the few times she felt true fear. Now Nyarlathotep was sending her here, and she almost felt pity for those who would meet her... Almost.

She was once again flying one of those simple Anti-Gravity transporters that Hordak had built. Blackwind was hiding in the wilderness, but she could feel his presence all over her. She told him not to hunt intelligent beings, if that was what the inhabitants of this planet were supposed to be, but she couldn't blame him for eating someone. She was resting lying on her back, and the vehicle was being driven by the cultists. Her body wasn't really getting tired, but she was enjoying being lazy. Besides, she could think about a few things before they got there. Despite everything, she came to the conclusion that she had made a few mistakes. It was hard to understand, but even perfect beings like

her sometimes made mistakes. That attempt to get rid of Adora was unnecessary, premature.. Another time she would have exacted Revenge on the usurper, when the Creeping Chaos would be more kind... She had time after all, she could live for a Millennium, and all she had to do was wait a few years and establish her position, and the Dark Sorceress would cease to be useful, and there would be no reason to honor the agreement she had made with her. Then she would be able to exact just vengeance on both girls, and perhaps their children. A vengeance carefully planned and thought out in the smallest detail. A vengeance so terrible that even after many generations people would tremble when she remembered it. She smiled to herself, this would be a wonderful future…

First, however, she had to deal with the present. It required absolute focus, and nothing could distract her. Above all, she couldn't let herself be captured. Fortunately, the locals didn't have good intelligence, let alone the secret police. Few had seen her, she had never posed for a single photograph, so it would be difficult for them to get a good quality likeness of her, and on top of that, you could look. Of course, she stood out for her beauty and general magnificence, but if she dyed he hair, maybe she would change her hairstyle... Although the latter would be difficult, after all, her regeneration was a problem. She will have to use her willpower to maintain her new hairstyle until it takes hold. She also needs to get a new outfit, because although she liked the dress, it was impractical in the swamps she was going to. She would also be harder to recognize in her new outfit, so she should change it even more. However, she had to admit that it was Nightgale's actions that contributed most to their escape. Glimmer, deprived of her power, was unable to reach them, in fact she was becoming someone extremely useless, she was not surprised that so many did not want her in power. Of course, most of the princesses were completely useless, dim-witted, and unworthy of what they were given. Maybe she could do something about that too, give it to beings far more deserving of such power, who would rule this place in a way that would make Horde Prime seem benevolent. Together, they would teach the Etherians what

it meant to respect the true rulers of the universe. She smiled to herself. Those were beautiful dreams, good dreams.

At night, they reached the cultists' shelter in a small town by the lake. It was deep, and its black waters reflected the light of the local moons. She had heard a lot about such places, some of the Great Old Ones liked to hide at the bottom of such bodies of water. Of course, these beings never lived in places where people worshiped them, because even though they were much weaker than the Outer Gods, no place in the mortal realm could withstand their power. Such places were like portals to pocket dimensions inhabited by such divine creatures. She wondered if that was the case here.

They went to the tower overlooking the lake. They were greeted by an older, very thin man, a man without any admixtures. There was a sense of power and strength in him, and his blue eyes gave the impression that a storm lived in him. Despite his age, he was quite handsome. There was none of the typical humility of cultists.. She was pleased with this meeting. The man silently showed them to their rooms. There were three of them, a stocky man, somewhat resembling a Bugbear , and a quite a tall and pretty girl, with elven ears and short goat horns and sad eyes. In more civilized lands she would be considered something like a faun, but here her species, or rather the people, as you would like to call it politely, were simply called horned ones, although several other peoples were also referred to in this way The girl reminded her of Klementine in her own way , both of them were innocent and not fully aware of who or rather what they were working with. Although this one gave the impression that she was smarter and much more determined to take the necessary steps to implement their plans, or rather plans of the Creeping Chaos. She was pretty too, she couldn't deny that. So they were given a room, rather cramped, but for a while she would have to be content with some discomfort, and they could take a nap. However, when night came, she decided that she would not rest. She stood up and started looking around the entire building. More common creatures would have considered such behavior rude, but she had the right to go wherever she pleased , no one was worthy of

forbidding her anything, at least no mortal. The building had several floors, was rather cramped and modest, but had the impression that it was adapted for a larger number of inhabitants. At the top were much more interesting rooms. There was a library, not very large but it had some interesting volumes. There was the Book of Dead Names, and it was a very good copy, not the edited version that most cultists had. There were also Revelations of Glaaki, which she had expected here. However, to her surprise, in the place of honor was a book titled The Truth of the Moons.. Intrigued, she started looking through it and couldn't hide her disappointment. It talked about us about matters related to astrology and the movements of the moons, things that only the inhabitants of this backwater planet could be interested in. She closed it with a bang and heard a loud smacking noise behind her. She slowly turned around so he wouldn't think she was scared and saw the same older man who had greeted them.

„Quite a nice bookcase for such a modest household!„ She said, smiling at the man, who frowned at the bottle as he ate it trustingly.

„No! I've only just started collecting it, and it'll probably keep growing for a long time. Especially since it's now easier to import books... and other valuable... things... from all over the Galaxy.„ he said in a new voice. She turned her head to the side and asked.

„Who do you serve? „ She walked up to him and touched his chest. „ Because you probably don't serve my master, as I thought earlier?”

The man's eyes lit up with a strange inner light, as if he was more than he seemed.

„I don't serve anyone. I protect knowledge! I am looking for what is on the verge of oblivion... I am fighting with blissful ignorance! People like you cannot understand this.„ You could hear pride and confidence in his voice. For a moment she felt like ripping out his

liver... Such arrogance towards a being infinitely better than him... but she made her curious.

„Who are you? Your words show that you are not like the inhabitants of this planet. There is determination and strength in you, as well as respect for knowledge. Was it hard for you to live in the land of ignorance?„ She walked around him because there was actually something strange about him. He looked old, but he was undoubtedly much fitter than he seemed. He didn't seem to be afraid of her, although he should have known who he was dealing with...

„I have been many people, now you can call me an archivist. First of all, I collect remnants of lost magical academies. Many here would consider the knowledge gained there too dangerous to let it fall into the wrong hands. It's so funny to be so open and yet not believe that others will be responsible enough not to destroy themselves with ancient secrets.„ he snorted and shook his head.

"Magic Academies?„ She looked at him curiously, maybe she would actually let him live. At least for a while.

„Now there is only Mystacor... But there used to be more of them here, three to be precise. There were Arcanacor and Umbracor. They both destroyed each other...„ He said in a much friendlier tone

„Oh! I didn't think there were people with such character among the locals!" he exclaimed and laughed.

„This is not something to laugh about.... On the other hand, For people like you... We have to entertain you with our... short-sightedness. „ Now he has become much more reflective.

„Many things about Etherians make me laugh. But I didn't come here to joke. Apparently we have similar interests. I was ordered to investigate these lost academies. Or rather, what was left of them."

He nodded, as if he had expected such an answer, and said slowly and thoughtfully, in a voice deep and not quite befitting an ordinary collector.

„Come with me.„ He motioned for her to follow him . They found themselves upstairs, under a glass dome over which bright stars shone. It looked a bit like an observatory, but what was studied in the past, when they couldn't see it, was the stars. There were many objects around, most of them looking like works of art. On the platform of honor was another book, not very ornate, with a brown, probably rough, hard cover. The man approached the book standing on the platform. He opened it carefully, touching her tenderly as if she were a lover.

„Please read it.„ He said in a quiet voice filled with delight. She walked over to it and started looking through it.

„Research logs of the Head Sorceress Klea . This might be interesting, you're right.„ she said, smiling, although she was not very happy at the thought of having to spend a few hours reading the book. She was intelligent, and sharp, but she had little interest in poring over Ancient Tomes to extract bits of information from them, which is why she needed the Shadow Weaver. Well, this woman had a lot of flaws, but she was a great scholar who loved solving such puzzles. Unfortunately, she didn't have it on hand, so she had to fend for herself. She began to look through the book with some interest. She didn't fully understand the context, the dark sorceress didn't explain everything about the history of her planet to her, and she probably didn't know all the facts herself. However, from what she understood, the journal was written several hundred years ago, and the author lived at a time of some great crisis between the sorcerer schools. Everything was related to recruitment issues, as well as competition with the princesses ruling the planet. It might have been interesting, but historically speaking, she doubted it had any relevance to her current mission.

„Please take this, here I have condensed knowledge, topics that should interest you... „ said the man, handing her the book. It

was actually a notebook, it even had a grid, but after a cursory glance she decided it would be worth reading.

„You know a lot about my interests.„ She said, looking at the man. „ And I don't even know your name.”

The man smiled slightly before answering.

„Aharath , My name is Aharath. And you, my dear Calamity, are quite predictable. I know O just like you. I really know a lot, more than I would like. And while you may believe otherwise, you are not the greatest monstrosity in the galaxy... nor anything as wonderful as you seem to perceive yourself.”

She smiled at him gently. Hearing his words, she bowed slightly and left the room and went downstairs. She didn't knock, so she was surprised when she saw the woman was awake.

„What were you doing my lady?„ she said, looking at her with concern. It was almost as offensive as the words of the owner of this household, but after a while she accepted that it was normal behavior among mortals. A thought came to mind. She approached the woman and touched her as tenderly and gently as the other man touched the book, although the book was probably much more valuable than hers. She saw that the woman was interested, so she smiled and kissed her... At first, the girl was surprised, but also very willing. She was much more experienced than her, which was a strange experience. After a few quite long and pleasant moments, she felt that her body was giving in to ecstasy. If that was what love was all about, and she doubted there was anything more to it, she now understood why mortals succumbed to it so easily... She wondered what it would be like when that girl knew her true form, shouldn't the sensations be much more intense then? Anyway, after that, she started reading the book, which was surprisingly interesting. The girl tried to talk to her, but she signaled her to be quiet. There was no reason for you to bother her with problems like a mortal, even if she was quite pretty. The girl seemed disappointed and saddened, as if she expected a higher being to care about her feelings. She would

leave her behind sooner or later anyway, she wasn't valuable enough to bother with. In the morning she finished the book, and then she noticed that the mirror was pulsating with power, as they had agreed, now they were supposed to discuss further steps, and you learned a lot of new things. She told the two cultists to put the mirror upright so she could use it, and then she told them to leave. This conversation was not intended for the servants' ears. However, when the mirror was activated, to her surprise she saw a person there who she didn't expect.

„Good morning, Lady Cala . Although I don't know how I should address you... „ said Lady Sorrowflame, smiling slightly.

She wasn't in the company she had ever intended to be in, at least not in the last hundred years. And she was heading to the place she had decided to leave so long ago... Life had a cruel sense of humor, although she should have blamed it on the ancient evil she served. Nyarlathotep could be so human one moment that they could almost be mistaken for mortal, but in the next they revealed their truly terrible nature. Her sisters sat next to her in the same transport, bulky and clunky, and she could clearly see Hordak's hand in the design. It may have been ugly, but it was practical and cheap to produce.

Her sisters didn't look like they wanted to be here either. Well, how rarely could she agree with them. They had reason to be irritated, after all, she showed up at their embassy uninvited and unwanted. That day she found herself again in the dark, empty space extending beyond the world, although this time instead of people she took with her only a strange mirror, she had the impression that it charged with a cold even greater than what she experienced here. Then she landed in a large room, right in the middle of the embassy, and saw her sister dot. Midnight Mask was giving orders frantically, and Storm Heart was leaning against the wall, dark in thought, until she saw her.

„What are you doing here!„ Storm Heart shouted , drawing her weapon. Midnight Mask was much more reserved and didn't say anything, just looked at her intently.

„I just want justice to prevail and my justice to finally give me a just punishment.„ she said, smiling crookedly at her sister, who gritted her teeth angrily and drawled slowly.

„What are you planning!„ she threatened her with a gun. She smiled again in response, but this time warmer and friendlier, and then answered.

„I only want to save Etheria from destruction and ensure that justice is served.„ she put her hands in front of her to be handcuffed. But nothing was done, so she sat in the chair and closed her eyes. She must have been a very unusual sight, one of the most despicable and hated people on the entire planet sits in an armchair like a Tired Grandma. She was in her sisters' private living room, in the living area of the embassy. Two or three of the servants saw her, but they were well trained and did not ask any questions, and probably pretended that nothing had happened and had not seen anything. She trained similarly her Horde wards, as well as the soldiers serving her. She smiled darkly to herself as she realized that even then she was imitating what she had been taught at home. Now she wondered if she had ever really escaped from her past Didn't it follow her wherever she went and infect every place she went with what she hated? She started laughing and her sisters looked at her, probably thinking she was crazy. Maybe they were right, but it's probably better for everyone that she wasn't. For the next hour, absolutely everyone avoided the living room, as if it had become an unclean place, sullied by something vile. In fact , you could say that it was. However, her sisters kept their eyes on her, they thought she couldn't hear their whispers, but her shadows were listening to them.

„We shouldn't take her. She wants it!” Storm Heart said angrily but Midnight Mask replied in a calmer voice.

„And what are you going to do? Do you remember what happened last time, we can't defeat her! You can try to poison her, but that's probably my style. And even if you succeed, what? Will you kill her on the spot? Will you drag us before the Mother? Oh no, I'm sorry, is that what she wants from you? So please tell me, sister, what are you planning? Because I don't think you have any plan, as you always do."

„We can hand her over to the local queen, you heard what happened, what she and the other girl did...„ Storm Heart She could barely keep herself from chaining herself.

„You want to make a one from our family be judged by strangers. Infidels have no right to do this!„ Midnight Mask's voice was full of malicious satisfaction. Storm Heart drawled slowly

„So why do you think you have the right to judge any of us?"

This time, her other sister fell silent for a moment, then drawled slowly.

„Be careful, dear sister, that you don't say one word too many, I have ways to hurt you, don't forget that...„ she seemed to be completely serious and ready to fulfill her threat. She wasn't surprised. If anyone found out about her apostasy, she would be exiled... at best. Their discussion reminded her of her youth... They had changed so little, they were still those two women who fought for their mother's favor. Only the world had changed around them, something they didn't understand. She laughed again, softer this time, and fell asleep. While she was sleeping, it was already dawn. She didn't have any dreams, which she thanked fate for, even though she knew she should be thanking someone else.

Black Blade announced that they were ready to go. She also informed her mother, who was expecting them in the capital of the country, about everything. Storm Heart looked at her suspiciously, but didn't say anything. Well, perhaps the eldest of the sisters, the one they had never respected and had always

considered naive, had for once shown the greatest sense.. She guessed no one thought that she could seek refuge with her sisters. Probably most of the inhabitants of Etheria did not think that she had siblings. Glimmer probably knew who ruled the Isles of Sorrow, and perhaps Catra and Adora and some the other princesses, too, but most of them lived in blissful ignorance. In addition, most people assumed, and rightly so, that the two women would be of no help to her and would hand her over at the first opportunity.. Of course, the most important thing was that the people of Etheri were not in the habit of punishing others for the mere suspicion of committing a crime. She could therefore reach the coast uninterrupted, but even so the sisters were vigilant and cautious, a trait typical of those raised in a country where loyalty and trust were the most precious treasures.. They were near the Coast, she straightened up and turned to her sister.

„We have to stop.„ she said and they both looked at her as if she was breathing fire.

„What are you planning? „ said Storm Heart, looking at her carefully, as if you wanted to read what Conspiracies were born in her heart.

„I need to talk to your niece.” she explained with a slight smile. She frowned

”You were talking about her, and then Midnight Mask confirmed that you were telling the truth. But you haven't explained who she is or, more importantly, who her father is, although I have some suspicions about this.

She had no intention of explaining her relationship with her daughter to her older sister, at least for now , because it was new to her too.

„It doesn't matter, fulfill my request, we both have Etherai's best interests at heart. And it, contrary to what our Mother taught Us, is important for all of you.”

Storm Heart She looked at her speechless, but finally spoke

”You are the prisoner here! You are to obey our orders!” She stood up and grabbed her glaive as if she was going to strike her, which was surprising because in all the years they had lived together on the Islands of Sorrow, she had never raised a hand to either of them.

„Do what he says.„ said Midnight Mask, they are watching her carefully.

"But she's…" The storm guardian protested, but the black blade prevented her from finishing.

„You have to do what I say!„ she ordered sharply, and for a moment the two women stared at each other, but there could only be one result. Storm Heart looked away, pursing her lips angrily, and Midnight Mask ordered them to stop. When she heard to leave, she said something else.

„Someone unpack this mirror I came here with and take it wherever I say.”

Midnight Mask gave her a murderous glare, but ordered her servants to do as she said.

She ordered a mirror to be placed on a low Hill with thorn bushes growing around it . The planet was so sparsely populated that no one lived in the area, and it was unlikely that anyone would notice them. It was dawn, and several moons illuminated the hilly plain. She felt the power emanating from the mirrors and spoke the words.

„Through nothingness together.„ Her throat still hurt as she spoke the words in that terrible language not made for mortals. Then the characters of her interlocutors appeared. First she saw Lady Cala, in a dressing gown, leaning on her hip and smiling with indulgent superiority, as always. The image in the mirror split in half , which was an otherwise useful feature, and in the other half

a person appeared who she wasn't expecting, but who wasn't as surprising as she should have been.

„I don't think anyone expected you here, Lady Sorrowflame .„ she said to the woman with flame-colored hair. She was on a ship of some sort, and in the background stood LadyKa in the shadows. Lady Sorrowflame only smiled slightly in response.

„I thought that establishing contacts with you could be very interesting and, what's more, very useful. I serve the Lord Admiral, but I am not his subject... I have my own goals that I am determined to achieve. We had a brief chat with your ward during the wedding of the Lord Admiral's daughter, and she is someone who knows far more than most of the inhabitants of this planet. This place hides a lot of secrets, which you probably know because you've been here. I don't believe you came here just to exact revenge on your former charges, or should I say your daughters? Mrs. Ka shared with me what you said during your conversation with Antares , and you didn't sound like the mean and vengeful witch your daughter thinks you are. „ explained the necrotechnician . Lady Cala raised an eyebrow, as if to show her that she could make friends too, and not with just anyone.

„ But dear Lady Sorrowflame , I am a mean and vengefull Witch, and also power-hungry and treacherous. „ she said to the necrotechnician , and then added.„ However, in fact, I did not come here to punish anyone, but to fulfill a mission... The fate of all of us depends on its success. „She hoped, it doesn't sound too high-flown. Lady Sorrowflame nodded as if she had expected this answer and said.

„I am not guided by mundane motives either. Now I am a necrotechnician working for the Lord Admiral, but for millennia I was a priestess of Dahak , but my God died along with all of Golarion .„ she said, and you could hear sadness in her voice. She hurriedly tried to remember who Dahak was . He was probably the God of destruction and Rebirth? This didn't portend anything good.

„It's good to see someone with a heart full of faith in this place , it's so comforting! Please wait a moment until the third person who is a member of our pack appears... „ said Lady Cala, smiling warmer than usual.

Nightgale materialized next to her ...

Chapter End Notes

This chapter has grown larger than it should have

Grimm Covenant - part two

Leaving Castle Crypto wasn't too difficult for her, after all, no one was stopping her, and she could use the datapad and had instructions from Dr. Moors, who already knew the castle well enough to be her guide. She once considered him a potential ally, but her mother had a very low opinion of him and didn't trust him at all, so she decided that he would share her opinions. However, she could not refuse his help. When she returned to the castle that had been her home for much of her life, she failed to achieve anything she had planned. She didn't meet with Lonnie and the others, only Kyle nor did she get important information that would help them in their mission. She learned some interesting things, but she didn't know how to use them. That's why she needed the brain in cylinder hat, if only because of its contacts with Mi-Go. Therefore, in order not to discourage him, she did not interrupt him while he was talking about her recent companions.

They finally made it out of the castle, and just as she felt fear when she came back, now she felt an indescribable sadness as she left this place, probably forever.

When they left the castle, she went straight to the village where she had stopped earlier. The residents didn't even seem to notice that they were gone, nor did they seem to notice that she was back. Not even Dr. Moors piqued their interest, although anywhere else the sight of a black cylinder with metal tentacles would have caused a stir at best. Even the brain in cylinder hat was confused by this indifference. Apparently, such were the settlements where Nuclear Chaos had been worshiped for centuries. How many generations has this been going on here? The Dryl Mountains have always been a mysterious place, full of people who chose their own way of life, often so difficult to understand for the rest of the planet's inhabitants. What was this place like in the time of the First Ones? And what was its story? She could only guess at that. She stayed in the same shelter open to everyone where she

had rested earlier. No one disturbed the peace of the three of them, well, three of them...

The Star Saihe disappeared as soon as she entered the castle, and did not appear the entire time she was there. He has only now returned.This didn't surprise her, after all, he probably had some business of his own, and it was better not to find out what it was, and she preferred to rest from his company for some time. However, judging by his expression, he seemed impatient, and maybe even concerned.

„We haven't seen each other for quite a long time.„ she said to him when they got to the shelter.

" I had many duties. My student Claudia must have done some preparations, although I'm still not sure if she'll be able to perform the ritual... Your mother's help would really be useful.„ he said, in a thoughtful voice she had never heard from him before.

„I guess you'll have to wait for her. We have only just started our journey. Is that why you haven't contacted me?"

The Star saihe shook his head.

„This Castle has defensive wards. Its creators opposed the power of our former masters. That's why they built it. The whole of Dryl was a stronghold against the power of the First Ones. however, its inhabitants were not warriors, but engineers and scientists. They wanted to survive, not fight. They were such intelligent people, but they didn't know that you can't win the war without fighting. But they survived, so maybe they made good choices?"

She didn't even feel like responding to his argument. She had a lot of worries on her mind anyway, and she wanted to have fun with an self-madet philosopher.

„Who are you talking to? Are you delusional? Have you suffered a brain injury? It's possible, we don't know how the ritual you performed affects your mental health and nervous system.„ She was diagnosed by Dr. Moors.

She didn't feel like talking to him either, so she just replied.

„Yes, these are terrible delusions. You'll pick my brains out through my nose in your free time, now don't disturb me.”

The Saihe laughed, and the brain in cylinder regarded her with its artificial eyes with suspicion and resentment. Ignoring him, she prepared to astral projection. She held a lock of the Mother's hair in her hand and uttered the words of the spell. Soon she felt herself leaving her body and bringing herself. She kept her eyes closed the whole time. Although it wasn't really necessary, it made it easier to avoid dissociation while transferring her mind. When she opened her eyes, she saw her mother, still tired and depressed. Opposite somewhere was a silver mirror that was divided vertically in half. To her left was Lady Cala, smiling as always with indulgent superiority, but to her right was someone whose presence she hadn't expected. Lady Sorrowflame was watching them, her hood was pulled over her head, she was smiling mysteriously.

„So we're all here... You asked, Lady Sorrowflame, what our goal is. Well, neither of us knew completely selflessly. I'm looking for a way to fulfill my destiny, Shadow Weaver wants to protect her’s charges, and our companion, Nightgale, currently just wants to survive, and what motivated her before. Unfortunately, I don't know.„ The aristocrat looked at her with a raised eyebrow.

„Just like you, I had an agreement with our... superior. „ She smiled and looked at the others, not sure how much she could say.

„Yes, you were the one who performed this ritual... I can feel the power you summoned, it was impressive.„ Said the necrotechnician, and she looked humble in response.

„Praise from someone like you means a lot, all the words of appreciation go to my teacher, without whom I wouldn't have had enough knowledge to perform it. Although, as you can probably see, it didn't turn out very well... „ she smiled sadly... When she

mentioned the teacher, her mother clenched her fists in anger. She had already noticed that she didn't like the Star Saihe...

„I came here following the Lord Admiral, because I have been serving his family for many generations. I didn't expect much from this place. I remember many fallen civilizations, the place where I was born was full of ruins, but I discovered that this planet not only had the Second Starstone, which as we all know is one of the most powerful artifacts in the galaxy, but it also missed the Gap…... Even I, despite my Millennium-long life, have not escaped this curse…I don't remember most of my life, and more importantly, I don't know how I lost my God. He was destroyed along with Golarion. I want to find out what happened to him, if possible, take revenge."

„Golarion, I heard this name recently... Does you come from this planet?„ she looked at the woman with fiery hair, remembering the recent clash with the inquisitor. He said something about Golarion... It and the Starstone... but what? She had to remind herself, but she wasn't sure how much she could trust the Lord Admiral's servant.

„Yes, just like Starstone. Unfortunately, it was destroyed, but nothing knows when or how... Both Azlanti and many gods, as well as a significant part of humanity, come from there. It is on its former orbit that the Absalom station circulates... Thanks to the Starstone, it is possible to travel by drift drive... Why, you ask? Where have you heard this name?"

She hesitated, looked at her companions, unsure whether she should tell the whole truth...

„Before we start sharing knowledge willingly, let's establish one thing... How much can we believe that you are not following Antares' orders now? So far, there has been no way there. I know who this man is in history, and I have already learned his true colors.„ Shadow Weaver looked at Lady Sorrowflame, standing behind Lady Ka, who smiled at her as she wanted to rip the skin off her face.

„Well, you have no reason to trust me. I admit that the fate of the Lord Admiral is not completely indifferent to me, because for several generations I have had a hand in all the undertakings of his family, and I am very proud of my works. I won't abandon them for any reason, regardless of what you think about his actions. This does not mean that I will follow all his orders. As I told you, I am not his servant, but his employee.„ She said in the calm, matter-of-fact tone of a scholar. She was disturbingly reminiscent of her mother now, though MUCH more composed, as if she had control over all her feelings... Or, her heart was cold and dead... She remembered what the guards had told her about her as she prepared to release Shadow Weaver.

„You are not mortal. I heard about what you did at the wedding. They said you were a dragon. The real one, the first one to come to Etheria in millennia... But you're not just a dragon... „ She said, looking at the necrotechnician. Lady Cala smiled, obviously she already knew that.

„Yes! I am a vampire, ancient and powerful. And also a scholar and a Necromancer. Once I was known as Ashaq the Annihilator. I was a priestess of Dahak, but you already know what happened to him..„ she had the impression that pain appeared on the face of the woman with flaming hair. Her mother seemed slightly confused, Well, Shadow Weaver spent most of her life on Etheria, where Religion was not widely practiced.

„So you want to learn the secrets of this planet to find out the fate that befell your God?„ the inhuman aristocrat nodded and added. „We can help you with this... This place is connected with Golarion... Today I managed to get some information... It was a lucky coincidence, but it can be very helpful to you. There were three magical colleges in this land. Only one survived , and the vast amount of knowledge that had been accumulated was lost. However, Not all... Go to the ruins of Umbracor. Those who taught there believed that this place must escape from Despondos, from the prison in which this planet was locked. They are looking for a way to do this and created Stelarium. Thanks to it, they managed to recreate both the appearance of the First One’s Empire and the

universe as they knew it. This device, if I may call it that, allows us to trace the history of this ancient people. As we all know, Well maybe not all,„ She looked towards Nightgale „ They visited Golarion. Maybe you'll find the answers there. We also entrust ourselves to go there...„ the aristocrat smiled broadly.

„Unfortunately, I advise against it. While we were separated, I talked Mikah, Castaspella and Hordak into going to those ruins, I don't want them to get hurt.„ Shadow Weaver said sharply, staring at her charge. Lady Cala smiled, genuinely amused.

„It's a pity you didn't warn you earlier. We would run into each other and someone would get hurt.”

„I wasn't sure if they would go, and I still don't know for sure, and anyway, I was about to say it, but Lady Sorrowflame joined the conversation and things got a little more complicated.. Besides, you are bound by your oath and you cannot harm Castaspelia and Mikah. „ Said the Dark Sorcerer firmly. She didn't miss the fact that she didn't mention her father, as if she didn't care about his life. She wasn't sure what she should think about him. He banished her from his domainr, when she was most vulnerable. But still, she always wanted to meet him, perhaps just to tell him what a bad father he was. How much she suffered because of him... If he died now, she would be deprived of this chance...

„I will try to avoid confrontation with them. After all, we are still allies, even considering Glimmer's completely nonsensical allegations... The Lord Admiral would not want anyone to spoil his relationship with his daughter, and I see no reason to make enemies of the inhabitants of this planet. So I hope we don't get in each other's way. You can treat this as a nod to mutual cooperation. „ The ancient dragon in the flame-haired woman's body was serious, and it seemed they could trust her on this matter. Lady Cala winced slightly, but it was barely visible. “However, I would like to know what you are looking for there? Because I don't believe you are interested in the history of this planet forgotten by gods and demons... At least not in itself.”

At this moment, both the blonde aristocrat and the Dark Sorceress were silent, as they agreed that they should not reveal this matter to the ancient dragon. But she had a different opinion about it, so she said it.

„We are looking for a way to Xadia, another planet that the First Ones turned into their research facility.

At that moment, she felt as if the redhaired woman's eyes lit up with flame.

„ Oh yes, I've heard of this place, a planet whose inhabitants are humans, elves and dragons. This could be a very promising place! I need to learn more about it… About it, and about the ancient sorcerer who lives there, Aaravos... „ When the name was mentioned, she felt worried. She felt as if the persona of the Star Saihe was surrounding them more and more, as if it was all part of his Grand Plan. It was quite probable, after all, he was the chosen one of Nyarlathotep, who could plot intrigues throughout the Milenia. Could they also be just pawns in the Great Game of ancient beings? Even someone like Lady Sorrowflame could become a tool in the hands of beings older than time itself. For a moment she felt overwhelmed by the scale of the events in which she was participating. They were all just cogs in the infinite machine of universes. The Lord Admiral and his daughter, Lonnie's rebellion, All the suffering she has experienced in her life. None of this mattered. It was both comforting and terrifying.

„I know who you're talking about, I know very well. I talked to him today, actually even now. I can try to ask him... I just have to try to look into my body for a moment.„ She said and tried to return to her body, but not completely so as not to break the connection. She felt terrible nausea as she began to experience both realities at once. But Aaravos was there, smiling as always, both curious and bored.

„Could you come to where I am?„ she gasped with difficulty. Star Saihe nodded, and she immediately returned to your interlocutors, and she would have fainted. He was already standing there next

to them, as ghostly as she was, though visible only to her. All the women looked at her, and the ancient dragon raised one eyebrow

„So he's next to you now?„ the woman with flaming hair asked with her deep and strong voice.

„Yes, if you want, you can ask him something... „ She said, and the wizard standing next to him smiled.

„Oh really?„ Lady Sorrowflame's voice was filled with doubt. „ Then tell me who the inhabitants of his planet are. Star Saihe thought about his answer for a few moments, and then he finally said.

„ It was originally inhabited only by dragons, but now hybrids of elves and dragons live here, as well as hybrids created from human workers and officials of the First Ones. Is this answer satisfactory?

Lady Sorrowflame nodded and then asked another question.

„Then ask him whether his world was affected by amnesia, a great loss of memory to which all the inhabitants of the Galaxy fell victim several hundred years ago.„ This time she saw sparks of wild flame in the ancient dragon's eyes.

„No, like Etheria, such an event did not happen here.„ she repeated the Sorcerer's words. The Necrotechnician nodded again and asked another question.

„Then tell me what the fate of my planet is, Golarion.”

She saw that the Star Saihe was now smiling broadly and cruelly.

„Yes, he knows, but he won't tell you the truth. This is something you have to discover for yourself.”

This time, a fire flared in Lady Sorrowflame's eyes, and she and her mother felt an instinctive sense of dread. Even Lady Cala seemed a little concerned.

„Don't play with me! I demand answers to my questions!„ said the ancient dragon. They had the impression that if they stayed with her, only ash would remain from one of them... Only the ancient sorcerer remained unmoved.

„You will learn the truth in Stellarium, because seeing is believing. When you go there, you will know the truth... But the truth can break „ He laughed quietly when he finished. She repeated the sorcerer's words and looked at him for a moment, wondering whether she had made a powerful enemy. But Lady Sorrowflame smiled, showing her long fangs.

„It is better for you that this is not a fraud, because my vengeance will be terrible.„ Her voice was quiet and gentle, as if she was not suggesting the terrible things she might do to them.

„Absolutely None of us doubts that you are capable of turning our lives into a nightmare, but we are not deceiving you, I can guarantee that.„ Lady Cala said, as if she was trying to reassure someone as fearful as Kyle... Her mother, however, seemed to be more distrustful, as if she suspected Star Saihe of betrayal. Maybe she was right, she wasn't sure how much she could trust someone like that... Wasn't all this just another experiment of the ancient sorcerer?

„So that's settled? Now I guess we just need to figure out how we meet? Having Lady Sorrowflame grace us with her presence made things easier for us logistically, since as you've probably noticed, our friend Nightgale has had an accident and her time is limited..„ said the aristocrat from a distant planet, pointing at her. „I suggest we meet on the way to Krannor Rill...„ She began to explain the best place they could meet, and the necrotechnician and her mother listened carefully, and then Lady Cala asked. „Did you manage to find out anything in Castle Crypto?”

She hesitated because she didn't know how much she could say about what she learned there. She didn't want to break the trust of her former comrades, and she wasn't sure whether such

information should be in the hands of someone like Cala and Sorrowflame.

„Not much, but I learned something. I found Dr. Moors in the castle, and he decided to travel with me, so we probably have Mi-Go's support... „ She looked at the necrotechnician, who, however, did not show that she cared in any way who he was with. they cooperate. „In addition, we met a machine built by the First Ones, which wanted to murder the inhabitants of the castle, and maybe even the entire planet, but was neutralized.„ Now she remembered what the inquisitor said, about Golarion being destroyed... For a moment you considered telling Lady Sorrowflame about it, but she decided it would be better if she found out the truth herself, especially since they had to get to the ruins of the former college anyway. . The other women listened to her, and then the ancient dragon spoke.

„Give me the location of this Umbracor. „ She demanded and at that moment her mother described to her where she should go. „ It's not far. I suggest we meet in two days, at the same time.„ The Necrotechnician finally stated, and then she started to disconnect the connection...

„ I just have to add that I managed to sort everything out with my sisters, although they are not very happy with my presence, but that doesn't matter..„ Shadow Weaver said finally. Once everything was said, they too began to break the connection and she returned to her body. When she opened her eyes, the sorcerer was floating beside her in thought.

„How did you like our new companion?„ she asked him.

He smiled and replied.

"Indeed, Xadia can be greatly enriched if such a person finds its way there. Archdragons will finally learn humility...„ he laughed in his deep and disturbing voice.

Calamity stretched, a little more content than before. The bit of entertainment she and her companion had allowed her to relax a bit. Sex is good, she will have to have it more often, although she could use more partners so that she doesn't get bored. She couldn't understand how mere mortals could get married and stay with the same person all the time. It was the opposite of the Idea of love... But what could she expect from vermin? Although bugs were sometimes funnier in this respect, for example Spiders... she giggled to herself at the thought... Maybe one day he would summon one of the terrible spiders from Leng, some of them he could pretend to be humans. The thought of spiders gave her an idea.

They ate breakfast, quite modest, consisting only of rolls with fruit preserves and dried fish. Their host was nowhere to be seen, apparently busy with his own business. She briefly explained to her companions what had been agreed. Of course, without going into details, after all, there was no reason, they saw about matters not intended for them. They listened to her without asking unnecessary questions, which is how exemplary servants should behave. Then they started getting ready to go. Then finally the owner of the place began to visit them. The man looked at them carefully until he finally asked.

„I hope my study helped you?”

She smiled brightly at him, as beautifully as she could, and then she came and said.

„Indeed, your help was invaluable. „ and she pulled out a bone blade from her forearm and then jumped towards him. He must have suspected something, because he took out some kind of weapon from his pocket, apparently a pistol, and even shot her, but a strange sharp dart entered her body and had little effect. The blade pierced his stomach and she twisted it and pulled it upwards.

„This is the price of disrespect! Now you'll be dying in your own blood, you worm! May you die for days for your crimes!„ She said

and kicked the man. Then she looked at her companions and said.

„This is the price of arrogance and lack of respect for those better than yourself... „ she said, smiling happily at the horror that appeared on their faces. This finally improved her mood. Let Hastur and the seventh Latto torn apart the feline monster and her thieving whore! She will always be better than them! Even if the whole universe adored them, they would always be just worthless finds. She took a deep breath and ordered them to get into the transport, because, as she guessed, the locals might be interested in the screams. This can lead to complications. Of course she wasn't afraid of them, she was only afraid of two things. Creeping Chaos and Evangeline…

The First Thunder - part one

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She didn't like these mountains because there was something overwhelming and disturbing about them. An eternal storm raging over the peaks that looked like fangs or daggers thrusting towards the She hadn't been here much during the war, the longest being when she'd been Kidnapped by Glimmer and Bow, which she still considered one of her stupidest failures.. Now she smiled at these thoughts because they seemed so far away. Unlike most people, she didn't enjoy remembering the past because it was too painful for her, but there were moments that she even liked remembering.

She stood in their tent, in the entrance. It had been set up an hour ago, it was spacious and colorful. It was a newer version of the old tents used during the war, but now, thanks to the efforts of Entrapta and the help of the people of Icarus, they had managed to improve them and now had heating and could become absolutely airtight, so those inside were absolutely safe from environmental threats, although did such things happen on Etheria? She sincerely doubted it. Things like this hadn't happened on their planet... Not since Entrapta had been hacking the planet's Energy Grid... Why was she going back to that time again? It was different now, she was on the good side, with her friends and wife. She turned and looked behind her. Adora was trying on the outfit given to her by her father-in-law, a large and, in his opinion, extremely valuable adamantium armor . Next to it, Melog looked on skeptically. It seemed to her that he was worried that because of the armor, he wouldn't be able to rub against. He always liked to leave his scent on her wife.

„It's... light! said her wife with surprise, she was almost completely dressed in armor, only her head was sticking out above the breastplate. She closed her hand and opened it several times. "I feel strong and capable in this, you know?„ She waved her hand, almost hitting the technician who helped her put it on. Her father sent it to her along with the armor. He was to teach both of them how to put on this armor. At first, she didn't think Adora would easily agree to Test the Lord Admiral's gift. On the other hand, even She, who did not wear any armor or armor even while she was in the Horde, could appreciate this armor... It was resistant, even her claws could not scratch it. They didn't test the sword of protection on him because they didn't want to stupidly destroy it, but it seemed to be able to protect them from everything Lonnie had... She clenched her fists. She already had reasons to be angry at her former hordemate, but since she had allied herself with Shadow Weaver, it was difficult to put into words the anger she felt towards her. She betrayed everything she said she was fighting for. She formed an alliance with a woman who turned their childhood into a nightmare. Maybe she had never been as nasty towards Lonnie as she was towards her, but she remembered well that today's Comrade General had been hit by the dark sorceress several times. How could she be so stupid as to trust her? Everyone knew that everything that woman said and did were lies, deceptions intended to subjugate others. Even Hordak fell victim to her manipulation. She may not have liked the former ruler of the Horde, but she could understand that even he could have fallen victim to her former guardian... her Mother. However, what Lonnie did led to the death of many people, including Brother Blade! Now not only was Hordak's former right-hand working with he, but so was this creature posing as Lady Cala. Her wife needed extra protection, not from a People's Rebellion, but before that, I'm going to make Shadow Weaver and her charges, not to mention this girl... Nightgale ...

„It's really comfortable, except... I'm not sure if I can take it off every time I want to transform into She"Ra... „ Adora asked in a slightly skeptical tone.

„When designing these armors, it was taken into account that one of the users had shapeshifting abilities. They adapt to the user's current form, because it is too expensive equipment not to take into account such an eventuality.„ Said a short, lizard-like individual with green scales. His people were called the Kablods, and they lived mainly in the Crimson Wastes. „ In fact, this armor could buy an entire warship. It's a truly extravagant wedding gift, although on the other hand, no one has worn it for years. This was usually the privilege of the spouse of the head of the Antares family, and as we know, our commander found no such person . It's a pity... I mean, it would be a pity if it weren't for you now, my lady.„ The technician stood up and gave her a humble bow. She felt a surge of pride. Her father gave her beloved such a great treasure so that she could be safe and not be harmed by those who had already caused them all so much suffering...

„Hmm... Are you sure? I mean, if it has changed, will I destroy all this armor?„ Adora looked at the small technician, who nodded hesitantly. She took a deep breath and called out.

„For the Honor of the Gray Skull!„ And a multi-colored light flashed and the entire tent was enveloped in rainbow brightness She used to dislike what accompanied her beloved's transformation into She-Ra because it brought back memories of how she had been abandoned, but now she had no problem with it.. She realized that each person is part of the one she loves. When the light dimmed, the Princess of Power stood before them. This time, however, she looked differently. She was dressed in white and gold armor, much more delicate than the one she had just worn. It seemed so fragile that one could feel that any blow would break it. Concerned by this thought, she approached her wife and the tip of her Claw touched the metal plate on her chest. It came over its surface, but did not leave even the slightest scratch. She pressed harder, and then harder, as hard as she could, but it didn't help. Even though she was able to tear apart armor plate, she couldn't do anything here.

„Is this how it's supposed to look?„ Adora asked, looking at her new outfit, which she obviously liked. She wasn't really surprised,

she looked beautiful in it, as if she should always wear it. Even the Melog wagged his tail with satisfaction

„Honestly, I'm not sure, but since no one is complaining and you're comfortable in it... „ said the lizard-like technician, scratching his temple. However, her wife did a pirouette and laughed. She didn't have a helmet, she hadn't put it on yet, but when they looked his way he was gone. Adora thought for a moment, then closed her eyes. Suddenly, a helmet appeared on her head.

„Do it as it was before.„ she said to her, and her beloved turned towards her and disappeared the helmet.

„That's better?„ she looked at her, and then she walked up to her, embraced her and kissed her. she felt a chill spread through her body. It was always like this when she touched, especially kissed... or did other things with her beloved when she was in the form of a Princess Of Power

„It's definitely better this way.„ she said and winked.

„Should we leave you alone?„ Kablod looked at them significantly. „ Because I see that some things are distracting you.”

She laughed, kissed her wife again, and then answered.

„No, I guess we'd leave. I guess we should show up at camp, right, honey?„ She looked at Adora, who grinned and said.

„Sure, I'd love to show off in this new armor. It's really very cool, and look how it sparkles.„ She laughed.

„It's good that there are no bright moons shining now, otherwise people who would see you would be blinded by your glow!„ She kissed her again and, holding her hand, they went outside.

She had to admit that it was cold, but from what she remembered, it was often colder here, and also weirder. There have been snowstorms high in the mountains, out of nowhere.

She had also heard from her soldiers who had served here during the war that they could hear Whispers and howling in the wind, though at the time she had dismissed it, yelling at them that they were cowards and were making up nonsense so they wouldn't fight. Now, after everything she had experienced in the last few days, she wouldn't be so sure.. Things were possible in the world that she had never dreamed of when she served in the Horde.

She wasn't sure what exactly the rebel military camps looked like during the war, but now they were well laid out and well protected against any possible enemy attack. She spent the entire previous evening and most of the night planning it, until Adora dragged her to bed, where she immediately fell asleep... She must somehow reward this care... she smiled to herself at the thought. The soldiers saluted them, or customarily waved at them, clearly happy to see She-Ra in her shiny new armor. She used to be jealous that everyone was so happy to see her beloved, but now she understood what a huge burden rests on Adora's shoulders. She was their hero, and the fear that she would let them down, that she would live up to their expectations, was like carrying a boulder a hundred times heavier than her on her back. It was a bit like each of these people was a tiny little Shadow Weaver which demanded too much for anyone to live up to. She wanted to help her in some way, and sometimes she succeeded, but with recent events, it was much more difficult. Adora blamed herself for not stopping Shadow Weaver and Lady Cala from escaping, or for not standing up to the monster that attacked Brightmoon , and suspected that she still resented herself for what happened to Light Hope, although she didn't feel sorry for that digital bitch. She remembered what that AI had done to her when she was in the crystal castle. She then considered abandoning the Horde and joining Adora... None of what happened later would have ever happened if it wasn't for her... However, her Wife saw something good in her, knew her the best of anyone alive, maybe saw something in her that she she couldn't There was also this kid, this young artificial intelligence, although it sounds strange because it was thousands of years old anyway, who wanted to kill her beloved out of revenge... But she could understand her,

because she saw what the pain of loss was, so she couldn't hate her completely, Although sooner or later they would have to do something with her, or else... She didn't know what, she would need Entrapta for that . The problem is that Entrapta was Kidnapped, and they had absolutely no idea what was happening to her, maybe something terrible happened to her. And Hordak, as if nothing had happened, went on an expedition with Micah and Castaspella . So much for his love and devotion.

They decided to leave the camp. Melog, who had been greeting all the soldiers who greeted them, and sometimes even brushed against them. They went to a place half an hour's walk from the camp. They found themselves on a rocky slope. They walked to the edge of the cliff, from which they had a view of the plains stretching at the foot of Dryl. Brightmoon was out there somewhere . But it was so far away... Just a few days ago they were getting married there and looking forward to their future together, and now... They were going to fight again, maybe even to war... They didn't want it so much ... None of them wanted it...

It all started after the funeral of the fallen guardsmen. Then Glimmer gave a speech about the courage and commitment to the values of those who died, and how their deaths were not in vain, and similar words... empty words. Glimmer was good at speaking, sometimes she could move crowds, but not then... She was clearly depressed, the events of the last few days had overwhelmed her, but not only that... She seemed pale, as if she was sick. You saw that something happened when they were chasing Lady Cala and Shadow Weaver, a man injected her with something and then ran away, turned into a bat... and finally into ash... That's what Bow claimed, but she had no reason not to trust him. It reminded her of another fairy tale from old of their superior-mother another one of those not-dead... She faintly remembered that story, but she remembered that there was something about the creature's bite ... that is, a princess with long fangs, as Shadow Weaver had coined it. Was the queen poisoned? That person didn't bite her, but I need to inject her with something. Glimmer claimed she was fine, even though her arm was still wrapped in a bandage.

She talked to the doctors without asking her friend's permission, maybe it wasn't quite right, but she had to find out. They claimed that they did not detect anything suspicious in her body, although the queen was not feeling well. Another reason for worry and anxiety. She sighed as she watched the slowly setting luminous moons. She sent Melog to watch over them.

„I guess after all this we need to go on a proper honeymoon...„ she said in a tired voice to her wife, and she smiled, she rubbed her head.

„It's not a stupid idea... Maybe, we will visit your planet. Your father said that your mother's people have their own world... Vesk V it is called, or something like that...

„Apparently it was conquered by the Vesks. We would probably start a new Rebellion after a week. „ they laughed together. „Maybe someday I'll go there, but for now, maybe we'll fly to the station on Absalom... Entrapta… She would like to go there...„ she felt a pain in her heart at the memory of her friend. She couldn't let anyone hurt her again! She just couldn't… She felt a surge of sadness and fear, so she hugged her beloved tighter. She was surprised when she felt her heartbeat. Surprised, but also reassured.

„You know, it's a bit of a pity. That this armor is taking off so slowly... „ she said and laughed, but then her wife looked at her armor, closed her eyes and the armor suddenly fell off. He became a gray and stubby suit of power armor again. Underneath, Adora wore her usual She-Ra outfit. Then she closed it again and then her outfit disappeared, except for the gold ruff. She was completely naked.

„Since when can you do that? „ she asked loudly, swallowing saliva.

„I guess from now on.„ she laughed and said. „ I'm thinking that we probably didn't have a real wedding night... „ She leaned over

her and kissed her. She put one hand under her shirt and started touching her breasts.

„Wait! I can't take my clothes off that quickly! „ she laughed and started purring.

She felt good... Her beloved's purring always calmed her down. For as long as she could remember, whenever she heard Catra Purr, she felt all fear and sadness leave her. Peace came over her, pure and absolute. When she held her in her arms like that, she forgot about all the evil in the world. There were only them. Everything else stopped mattering... She was just Happy. It had always been this way, and she hoped it would last forever.

„You know, I think we should get up, because someone else will see us, and it will be embarrassing. „ She said, but her wife laughed and said.

„Let them look! You deserve for others to see you the way I see you. Besides, Melog is watching over us . He will warn us if someone is approaching, and besides, everyone knows what it means when he is on guard... „ Catra said and kissed her. Their clothes were lying to the side. She had already returned to her true form, it turned out that she could make clothes appear next to her, quite a practical ability. Her wife's shapeshifting companion was far enough away to not disturb them, but close enough to run to them if needed.

„Yes, but I don't have to stay up all night like this. Some people will start to worry, and besides, when it gets dark it will be really cold.„ She said because she was starting to worry a little. It can get cold very quickly here in the mountains. Another hour or two and it could be below zero. They can't just lie here forever... Unless they take a tent... but I'll have to get up anyway, and if they get up and go to camp, they might as well stay there..

„Just a moment. A few minutes won't change anything,„ said her beloved, and she embraced and hugged him with all her strength. They lay like that for a few moments, but finally she asked something that had been troubling her since her conversation with Lady Cala.

"So you knew about what happened... „ She took a deep breath and continued. "About what they did to the former inhabitants of this planet... "Catra was silent for a moment, which was tantamount to confirming her words. She sighed heavily and said.

„When did you want to tell me about it?"

Catra looked down before answering.

„I don't know... I didn't want to tell you at first because you looked devastated by what happened to Angela. And then the thing with my father and sister came up, and then the wedding... There was no good time to tell you. I guess there's never a good time to say things like that... „ She looked her straight in the eyes and added. „ Do you blame yourself for that too? About wat your compatriots did...

She nodded and began to explain.

„From the moment I found out why the Heart of Etheria was built, I knew that the First Ones were not good. But, I didn't think they would do something like that. You understand that in times of war, people do terrible things. We both know that. But they murdered all the inhabitants of this planet. They stole the power I wield. Doesn't this mean that I accept the crimes they committed? For the evil that was theirs? I don't know what to think about it... I feel guilty, as if I had a hand in it."

Then her wife laughed.

„You're as stupid as ever. You cannot be blamed for what those who lived millennia before you did. You're not even one of them. Not with heart or spirit. They never did anything for you, and you destroyed their greatest treasure. You are an enemy to them just

like all of us.„ She embraced her and kissed her. She felt a little better, but there was another worry on her mind.

„You know, when I was reviving Klementine , I heard voices.„ she said carefully and saw that fear appeared on her beloved's face.

"it must have been because of exhaustion. Bringing someone back to life is not an easy thing, is it? Exhaustion makes people hear and see things." she said nervously, as if trying to convince herself.

„Possibly, but it was the same when I teleported here from Icarus... I heard them then too... They were saying something about a path... A shining path... I don't even remember what they wanted from me... Only that I was very afraid of it, that it caused This is unimaginable fear and sadness for me.„ she said quietly and shivered from the cold inside. Catra then jumped to her feet and screamed.

„Do not listen to them…! These are lies! Just like everything Horde Prime was saying... What these Eridani people are saying everywhere. You're not one of them... „ her beloved screamed, regardless of her nakedness. She hadn't seen her so angry since the end of the war... and scared... „You can't leave ... You just can't... „ she knelt down and started crying, and she hugged her beloved and said.

„I swear I will never leave you! He never listened to that hair. „ she said and hugged her until everything was dark.

It was already night when they got dressed and then they started walking back to the camp. They had not gathered a large army, and they did not want to give the impression that they intended to wage war. Of course, Brightmoon never really sent large forces into battle, at least not compared to what Catra's father had. They did not want to risk the lives of too many soldiers, they were not armed enough, and to engage in open combat with the Horde.

Now they were much stronger, they had many machines inherited from the Horde, as well as better equipment. Their opponent wasn't that powerful, it was just Lonnie and there were cadets... Though maybe she should have said as many as cadets. She knew well that they were highly trained. However, they were alone, there was no indication that the Republic of Snow or the Isles of Sorrow intended to support her. They weren't sure about the inhabitants of Dryl, who were theoretically subjects of the Comrade General. She didn't know what they would do if they had to fight the entire kingdom. So far, however, no one has resisted me, the locals have not run away from them, but they have not tried to help them uninvited either. Of course, they paid for all services, so everyone was relatively polite to them. They also managed to surprisingly quickly gather enough supplies to enable them to continue their activities for some time. They also received support from the Lord Admiral, who lent them several ships, as he called attack transports, as well as many soldiers. The former Star Siblings were among them. They were the ones who told the Lord Admiral that Catra lived here. All three joined the Fearless Armada and received new implants, weapons and uniforms. They only met once, and they didn't talk for long, but she was happy to have them around. She was much less pleased with the Lord Admiral's other subordinates. Lady Ka smiled at everyone, but in such a way that you were sure she wanted to hurt that person. This smile was even nastier than Lady Cala's , though she too smiled terribly. Except that the inhuman aristocrat looked at everyone with superior contempt, and the Lord Admiral's left hand seemed to think everyone was a funny idiot. It wasn't a significant difference, but it was still annoying. She could only hope that this woman wouldn't hurt anyone... But while Lady Ka put her at ease, the fact that Catra's father had also sent Lady Sorrowflame here almost made Glimmer explode. She herself was furious that Antares had decided to appoint her as one of those who would help them... Only Catra seemed to accept her presence, probably because the woman with the flame-haired woman claimed that she knew magic and could help them. in the fight against Shadow Weaver. Only they weren't sure how much they could trust such an ancient being. What exactly was she? A dragon? A dark

sorceress? Not-dead? All at once? The latter was probably true... Is the situation really so severe that they had to go so far as to cooperate with someone like that?

Melog joined them as they started towards the camp, probably keeping an eye on them the whole time, which some might find embarrassing, but her wife's shapeshifting companion had no interest in such matters. It opened up both of them, and he went with them into the camp.

Mermista with them , who also took some of her Azure Guard, as well as her husband, although Sea Hawk seemed surprisingly unenthusiastic about venturing into the mountains. It had to do with his past, he probably pissed someone off like always, or set something on fire and pissed someone off. At least that's what Catra thought. She wasn't sure where he found any boats or ships here, but there probably were some... and they burned down. Perfuma and Scorpia returned to their kingdom, because I need to rest after what happened, and besides, the former force captain wanted to see if it was possible to implement the machine diagrams into production, here the Lord Admiral gave her. They took this insectoid priest with them , who was said to have helped Frosta, although Catra was still hostile towards him. Netosa also joined them, after a tender farewell to her wife and children. They were very happy with her presence, because she was the only most experienced commander in all of Etheria , which was especially important after General Juliette was deprived of her position. Glimmer also came with them, but she rarely left the tent... And then there was the youngest of them

„You know what? Maybe we should look for Frosta? „ Her wife asked, raising her ears. „I haven't talked to her since leaving Brightmoon. I'd like to know if she's okay.„ she smiled, but in her eyes she could see that she was starting to worry. She was constantly worried about the Ice Princess. The girl was still sad and dejected.

„Sure! „It shouldn't be hard to find her. He's probably talking to someone around the campfire, or is telling her stories. „ she

replied, and she liked this idea very much. Even if the youngest of the Princesses did not go to the fire to warm herself with her friends and acquaintances, when they find her, they will definitely convince her to do so.

However, finding the girl turned out to be much more difficult than they expected. First they went to her tent, which she had pitched on the outskirts of the camp. It might not have been the safest place, but they didn't want to tell her that she might not be able to cope on her own. She had been depressed enough lately as it was. It wasn't one of those modern tents, but a traditional one used by the inhabitants of Her kingdom. However, there was no one inside, although it shouldn't be surprising, after all, they expected to find her in the camp. But still, Catra flattened her ears and Melog turned blue-yellow with Anxiety. They started asking the soldiers if they had seen her anywhere, but they all denied it. Now they were seriously afraid. Finally, when they were near the airport, they heard a distinctive hoarse voice that made all three of them stand on end.

„I see that the heiress doesn't sleep at night! Should I get you anything? I know you say you avoid such things, and if you change your mind, we have some herbs, or plain whiskey or vodka. It's really good, dwarf one. I won't give you any moshrooms lick because I still have strange dreams, not always pleasant ones, said Lady Ka with such exaggerated concern in her voice that it was almost poisonous.

„We're looking for Frost... we need to find her as soon as possible. „ Catra said sharply, looking hard at the woman. Lady Ka raised an eyebrow and asked.

„Oh, is that the little girl who was almost killed by that dark sorceress? I haven't seen her, but I can give you my trapper.„ She waved her hand and called someone. After a few moments, a tall man came to them, he was Saihe , but he was dressed in the uniform of the Fearless Armada, he also had several implants, as well as a cybernetic arm and an eye. His face was covered with tattoos, the meaning of which she didn't understand at all, but

then he wasn't from a fallen empire, she couldn't know much about him.

„I am Corporal Izai , what can I do for you?„ he said with a strange accent. After a moment, she realized that she had heard him before, but she wasn't sure where yet.

„We're looking for our friend, but I think we can handle it ourselves... We don't need help from someone from outside the planet... „ Catra said dryly, looking at the man suspiciously.

„Perhaps you do not need my help, although I served in the army for twenty years before I settled on Kesler and then I made a living from gunsmithing and tracking in the Settlement of my people, and after the destruction of the planet I serve in the Lord's Admiral army, so I have some experience tracking people.”

Catra was going to say again that they didn't need him, but he placed her hand on the rock and said.

„All right, you'll come with us. I hope you will be able to find our friend soon.„ she said, and gave a slight nod to your wife, who was still looking at the man distrustfully,

He nodded and said.

„What does your friend look like?”

„Short, dark blue hair, strong and wears leather shoes... „ she described briefly, and Saihe nodded and said.

„This is how I saw her leaving the camp.”

„ Then why didn't you tell me right away! „ her wife grabbed Saiha by the skirts of her boudoir and pulled her towards her. Lady Ka giggled , but she put her hand back on her beloved's disappointment.

„He didn't know it was Frosta and that she shouldn't have left the camp. In fact, there was no way he could forbid her from doing

so. She is a princess and took part in the war. Nothing happened to her! „ She calmed down the cat-like girl, who looked at the trapper with hostility, and Melog turned red with her anger.

„I'm sorry I didn't keep that girl, but I didn't know I should have. „ The trapper replied calmly, and her wife took a deep breath and replied.

„ All right. Take her to the place where you last saw her, but quickly. I have a bad feeling.” Her wife said

Chapter End Notes

And once again I've made a two-part chapter. I invite you to comment and I'd love to hear your opinions.

The First Thunder - part two

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Hunger woke her up. She hadn't felt anything like this for as long as she could remember. She liked to eat well, she never hid it. In her homeland, it was always good to be full to warm the body. Maybe it wasn't always as cold there as everyone thought, but it was quite cool. But this was something else. Something that prevented her from closing her eyes. In addition, she felt cold, in a different way, as if from the inside. She squirmed in her bed, unable to close her eyes, feeling as if she were sleeping on a glacier under the open sky. It was all painful, so she finally stood up and stretched.

„Well Shogi , we have to get up!„ she woke up her friend who was lying next to him in the form of a racoon. He opened all his eyes, he must have had eight of them, and yawned, but he probably wasn't sleeping at all. They went outside, where storm clouds were swirling. She liked Dryl, although she had only been here once or twice. These mountains were as wild as her home country. She remembered fighting a battle here with Mermista, not long after Adora had left the planet to save Glimmer. They then defeated Horde Prime's small army. She was very proud of this victory. Now they were also going to fight, but this time they were fighting against the other inhabitants of the planet. She didn't like the thought, she liked fighting, but now she felt like it was all wrong. She fought with Lonnie, she even helped take the kingdom from her, but now... She didn't know the point of it... Just recently she wanted to punch Lonnie in her stupid face. Of course, she was still mad at her, but in a completely different way than before. Now, she felt more pain than wrath. She wasn't angry, but rather powerless. Maybe it's because of the cold? So she got up and looked for a place to warm herself. A bit of

warmth will definitely do her good! She left the tent and started looking around the camp. It was noisy, but the old atmosphere of excitement and optimism full of uncertainty was missing. Once everyone knew what they were fighting for and what was at stake, especially during the occupation, and enthusiasm was meant to hide fear, but everyone also felt hope and believed that things would get better. But now everyone seemed depressed. No one liked the war with the People's Rebellion, no one wanted to fight the other inhabitants of the planet. And then there were the events that took place on the wedding day and after. Catra's father left them support, but everyone remembered what Lady Sorrowflame did when that monster comes. In addition, everyone knew that they would now fight Dark Sorceress and Lady Cala, who was a monster of her own kind. She saw her and her horse. She also saw what Nightgale was capable of. These were no longer fights with former cadets, but a real war in which many could die. No one knew what to expect, and no one wanted to fight alongside the Lord Admiral's men. Partly because they were strangers, but it wasn't because they came from a different planet or had different customs. They were strangers in a completely different way. When they helped guard the wedding, they didn't seem as threatened. they were simply soldiers who tried to fulfill their duties as best as they could. Then, when this mobilization was announced, everyone could see who they were. They did not hide the fact that they were going to fight and kill, for money for glory and for their Lord Admiral, and perhaps his daughter as well. They had no ideals in mind, and seemed willing to do anything if given the right orders. Everyone spoke of their professionalism and determination, but they seemed like cold ice that enveloped her heart. Only the soldiers from Bellum were like them, but everyone knew that they were complete crazy. And then there were these Dogs, subordinates of this half-masked woman. They looked like thugs, the ones who in stories attacked the defenseless in the mountains and forests, or in dark cities and settlements, but then the heroes always defeated them and distributed what they had stolen to the poor and needy. But they were released from the dungeons on the orders of Catra's father... As if he wanted to reward them for their villainy. That's why there

wasn't much singing or laughter in the camp. Everyone was gloomy and worried. Everyone knew they would soon have to fight, but no one was sure what for or why. Some people roasted sausages on the fire or cooked goulash, but most did not prepare anything. They just stared at the fire, thinking and sad. No one paid any attention to her, which made her feel even more lonely. Despite so many people, she had the impression that everyone was alone, or perhaps rather together with their friends and loved ones. However, she had no relatives, only friends. But friends are almost family, right? She thought about looking for Glimmer, or Catra and Adora, but there was another problem. She was still cold and felt a terrible, insurmountable hunger. Although she watched the food cooking with Fire, none of it looked tasty. Only a few cutlets from some Mountain animal seemed appetizing... She even stole one and devoured it when no one was watching, but it wasn't enough. She saw what she had to do. Following her instinct and fully aware of what she was doing, she left the camp with her companion and went to the mountains.

Even though she was cold, she felt that her coat was weighing her down, as if it was restricting her movements. She was half-naked, but she didn't feel the chill, not the external one. In fact, she felt like she had a fever. Her thoughts were muffled, she felt like she was walking through a fog, even though her senses were sharp. As if she had never seen the world so clearly. All the scents were so distinct, sharply pressing into her nostril. The smells of all the plants, all the weeds and herbs that have grown in the area. It was downright irritating, as was the stench of all those people in the camp, and the nauseating smell of the food they were preparing. It was irritating her, making her feel sick. She was hungry, but she had the impression that she wouldn't be able to swallow anything that was roasting over the fire. She growled quietly to herself, until her friend surprised her. He now took the form of a small weasel-like creature. Thanks to this, he was a great climber, which was perfect. They had to hunt. It was part of the Culture of her People, something not everyone on Etheria understood. Of course, they were careful not to over-prey, and they hunted only at certain times and in certain ways. But now

she didn't care anymore. First of all, she had to be satisfied, hunt something that would satisfy her hunger She began to sniff around, now she was as good at it as Catra. She kind of wanted to go back and tell her what amazing skills she had! This was amazing! She felt amazing! If only it weren't for that Hunger. But now she would satisfy it, she was sure. She had already discovered her prey, a small creature that lived in the mountains, climbing up rocky ledges. But now she would satisfy it, she was sure. She began to track it down, although she could see that it might not be easy. It was agile, jumping on almost vertical rock walls, but it wouldn't escape her! With her magic, she created handholds and places for her feet, now the cold didn't bother her There was a time when she always had to be careful when handling things made of ice to avoid frostbite. Now, however, she practically didn't feel the cold she had to protect herself from, not from the outside, because the inside burned like fire. She knew there was only one way to warm herself up. She was already close, the animal saw nothing, it was unconsciously nibbling on some thorny bush. It had three horns and three eyes. His fur was slightly bluish, a bit like the storm clouds above her head. It wasn't big, but it seemed to be very fast and she would have to use her wits to catch it.. She called on Shogi to help her surround the creature. Her friend, now in the form of a squirrel cat, cawed, and they attacked them from both sides. She licked her lips, it was unclear to her that her fangs were getting longer, but it was hard for her to think about such things right now. Her shapeshifting companion was ready. She gave him a sign. He ran towards the animal while she lay in wait. As it ran past her, she jumped out of her hiding place and ran at it. She formed blades of ice around her hands, and then she plunged into the animal's body. It let out a short cry, but then with another blow she broke its neck and then sank her teeth into its neck. She bit her throat and drank the hot blood for a while, and then she sank her teeth into the raw meat. She tore through flesh with her claws... Since when did she have claws? She didn't remember, but she didn't think about it either. She just wanted to satisfy her hunger. She ate greedily, as if she had been starving for years. She swallowed mouthful after mouthful of raw meat, unable to get enough. Every

now and then she would throw a piece to Shogi , who ate some of it, but most of the time he was staring at her with his many eyes, and she had the feeling he was worried about her. It made no sense, she had never felt so good! She was strong, invincible, a predator who could take down any prey! She could be proud of herself! She was no longer the little, stupid Frosta whom no one took seriously. The girl that even Her Own people didn't want. She was someone better! Maybe she'd live here in the wild, hunt forever? Have feasts like this every day? That would be a good future!

Finally she lay on her back, feeling freshly eaten meat in her stomach and blood in her mouth. She was wearing only a shirt and underwear. Everything was stained crimson , a visible sign of the feast she had just had. She hiccuped and smiled to herself. She was finally warm, she could even feel the heat that radiated from within her. She felt blissful, and she hoped that this feeling would never go away... And then consciousness returned to her. She looked around and saw the half-devoured body of the animal. All her clothes were covered in blood and pieces of flesh. She remembered everything she did with perfect clarity. It terrified her. She tore and devoured the animal herself. Of course, she had hunted but she had never eaten a whole animal raw. She killed them with magic, and not just tore them to pieces, but bit through its throat. She tore his flesh with her teeth and claws. She was like a wild beast! She touched her teeth and then looked at her hands. At first they seemed normal, but then long claws began to emerge from her fingers. She screamed at the sight, absolutely terrified... Was something happening to her, was it caused by the spell or by what happened to her while she was dreaming? She wasn't sure, but she was very scared! Was she turning into something? Some monster from legends? Her people had many stories of monsters eating flesh and men becoming beasts. Is this also what happened to her? She had to see herself, see if she was still Frosta Had she become a monster? She had to find a mirror or something to look at herself! But then she heard shouting. She recognized Catra's voice, even smelled her scent. They must have gone looking for her! She looked around again. They couldn't see

her like that! She had to do something! She had to run away and think about what to do! Terrified and in tears, she ran away, leaving behind the remains of the feast.

She didn't like this individual, not because he was a Saihe like Shadow Weaver. She knew many of his people, and she didn't dislike anyone, although she wasn't friends with any of them either, but she was always slowly making friends. She just felt like he was hiding something from her. He didn't fit in with the rest of her father's soldiers. He was very confident, yet very secretive. Perhaps all of his people were like that. She didn't know much about the Saihe who lived outside Etheria. Here, everyone rather identified with the kingdom they lived in, with a few exceptions... She winced as she thought about her adoptive Mother. To avoid thinking about her, she asked a question.

„Your people in the Galaxy have a different name than on Etheria, right? On our planet they name is Saihe, but on the Islands of Sorrow theynhave another name, although I'm not sure what it is„ She said, and the man turned to them and answered.

„We are called Elves, and this word, Saihe probably comes from Sidhe , another name for our people. I'm actually a Wood Elf, although that hardly matters now. Most of us live similarly to other species. My family... We tried to recreate the old lifestyle, or rather how we imagined it... But it was a long time ago. There's nothing left of it.„ his voice was hard, and his look was dark and painful. Then he turned back and started looking at the marks on the Earth. They were on a plateau, just above the camp. It was covered with bushes with hard, wax-covered leaves. She didn't know their name, maybe Perfuma would know what they were. Their branches were covered with thorns that caught on their clothes. It was very difficult for them to get through it, especially her wife complained about the thorns getting caught in her hair, since she was in She-Ra form again. Her armor was glowing gold again, they hoped it would be visible from a distance, and maybe Frosta would see her. Of course, this had its drawbacks, they

could also be seen by Lonnie's subordinates who might be patrolling the area, but she believed that the four of them could handle any threat. She reluctantly had to admit that Izai knew what he was doing. She had a great sense of smell and keen hearing, but she couldn't cope in the wild, especially in open spaces. Scorpia was already doing better in the art of survival, although many were probably surprised that such a good-natured woman, brought up in a giant factory, could easily cope in places so different from the Fright Zone. Maybe they could ask Bow to accompany them, but for now he was worried about Glimmer and her pregnancy. All they could do was rely on this Elf, which of course she didn't like at all, but there wasn't much she could do about it.

After a few minutes, Melog broke into a run and led them to the coat lying on the ground. She immediately recognized that it belonged to Frosta. Her companion began to sniff around, and she also began to look for a clue. She felt the scent of the ice princess, strong, with the aroma of leather and wool, but she also felt the strange scent of Frosta's companion , peculiar and impossible to confuse with anything else.

„Something happened. Something forced her to take off her clothes!„ she exclaimed, truly concerned. She was very afraid for her young friend. The elf motioned for her to let him look around. They soon found more clothes left by the Ice Princess. It seemed that she even undressed, almost demanding. Even though it was cold. For a few more moments, Izai looked around in silence while she thought about the strangest and darkest scenarios.

„I'm not sure, but it looks like she undressed herself. I don't see any signs of a struggle here. However, she was accompanied by a creature whose traces seem strange. It's as if this creature sees its shape every few steps. Slightly, but noticeably for a trapper like me.”

She nodded, somewhat reassured, and her wife nodded and explained.

„This is Shogi, our friend's companion, a shape-shifting creature. He looked a bit scary in his natural form, but he turned out to be very nice and quite useful. He became friends with Melog.

The elf nodded cautiously and looked at Melog with some distrust, then said.

„Since this creature was friends with your friend, no one attacked her. She had to take off those clothes of her own free will...„ Saihe said carefully, but it still irritated her.

„No one would willingly undress in such weather and in such a place!„ she yelled, making a wide circle with her hand. There were thorny bushes everywhere and there were sharp stones everywhere. A cold wind blew and stung her cheeks. Saihe sighed and began to explain to her in a calm voice.

„Sometimes when people are very sick or have hypothermia, they take off their clothes because they feel unbearable heat..”

„If she can be so sick, we must find her as soon as possible!„ she yelled at the man, who calmly nodded his head and signaled her to follow him. She was furious with him for how much he didn't care about her friend's fate. She ran ahead of them, leaving Saihe and her wife behind. Only Melog kept pace with her. She could now smell the distinct scent of Frosta, who couldn't be far away. She finally reached a rocky slope where she smelled blood. With her heart beating with fear, she ran in that direction. The smell got stronger and stronger until she finally saw the body. She froze in fear for a moment, and then she screamed.

„NO!„ and ran to the body. She was incredibly relieved when it turned out to be just an animal, one with horns and three eyes, but then she realized that whatever killed the creature might be nearby. She looked around as her shapeshifting companion sniffed around, as concerned as she was. She didn't see anyone, but she realized with horror that now this predator might be on the trail of The Ice Princess. She started looking for further traces of the girl, but found them nowhere, only trampled grass. She started sniffing

and didn't detect any foreign scent. Only Frosta and Shogi. She wasn't sure what it meant, Maybe nothing, Maybe the predator just didn't emit a scent, she didn't know anything about wild animals, and not about domesticated ones either. After all, Swiftwind and Melog, despite their appearance, were normal intelligent. Maybe some wild beasts living among the peaks of Dryl were able to hide their scent? Or maybe... Or maybe it was something even worse... An ancient machine left behind by The First Ones that had somehow awakened, or maybe it was some magical monster, like this not-dead one! She heard her wife land next to her after an extremely long jump. Behind her in the distance, the tracker ran, breathing heavily. She heard Adora inhale with a whoosh.

„Listen, it might not mean anything. It may have nothing to do with Frosta ... „ She spoke in a calming voice, but she growled in response.

„Look around! There are traces of it all around, and its smell!„ She looked at the heroine of the Galaxy as if she was deaf. Adora also turned pale, understanding what this could mean...

„Wait a moment... Izai will tell us more when she gets here... „ her wife explained in a ridiculously calm voice. Why didn't she understand anything? It was Frosta! A girl who had just escaped the clutches of death and still hadn't fully recovered. Without waiting for Adora's reaction, she started looking for the girl's clues. Unfortunately, she was shaking, and on top of that, the wind was getting colder , blowing sand and gravel.

„I'm already here! Let me look around for a moment!„ Her father's soldier called, breathing heavily.

„Where have you been! We don't have time, hurry, do you see any clues? Tracks of the girl and whatever killed that goat!”

Saihe mercilessly slowly knelt down and began to look around.

„The girl ran there, she was in a hurry. There was another creature running next to her, probably her companion.„ He started explaining, his voice as unwavering as he was giving a damn lecture!

„And the other creature? He has to chase her and she is sick…!„ she shouted at Saihe, who still acted as if he didn't care.

„I didn't see anything here that would indicate that there was a third person somewhere here... “ This time his voice was a bit more careful, she had the impression that she sensed anxiety in it. At last! But why did he say such things?

„What are you suggesting? She couldn't have killed that creature herself!” She looked past him, anger boiling in her veins. She hadn't felt it for a long time. This anger filling her through and through. It was like a cold flame burning in her veins! She hated this feeling, but at the same time she loved it when it filled her. Part of her knew she should reject it, push it as far away as possible, because it fueled the worst of her. But now she felt she needed that strength. This Rage and Fury

„I'm just saying what I see. I won't lie.„ He said, they were looking at her strangely, and she saw concern and anxiety in her beloved's eyes.

„That means you see shit. Show me where the tracks lead, and I'll run around there!„ She ordered firmly, in a voice that brooked no objections. Saihe looked at her seriously and then pointed in the direction.

„She moved in that direction quite recently.”

She nodded and together with Melog she ran in that direction. And there was a thunderclap in the sky, she had the impression that it had struck right next to her. A storm was coming.

She was scared. She was afraid of her friends. Not that they could do anything to her, because she saw that it was impossible. They weren't judgmental, especially Catra. She knew perfectly well that everyone makes mistakes and no one is perfect. But what she did… wasn’t bad in itself. In her homeland, they hunted, and it was considered normal… But, how she did it… That she tried to eat a hunted animal raw… That she practically tore it apart with her bare hands… Like some beast, some monster… That was what she was afraid of, That they would see a monster in her. Maybe she was becoming one. What would she do then? Will she still hunt when she felt this strong hunger? What will be visible at night to kill any animals? What if she can't find any? What if it's in space, for example, or in some larger city? What will happen then? Will she attack hers friends and tear them to pieces? This was what she feared the most... Would she become like those monsters in the stories... The ones who murdered their loved ones, who were unable to raise a hand against those they loved. She didn't want to hurt her friends, but what could she do next? Was she supposed to be hiding somewhere? Escape? Will you continue to live in these mountains with only Shogi for company? She had no idea, she had to think. That's why she climbed higher and higher, up the steep mountain wall. She created ice hooks, so it was n't difficult for her to stay on the stone surface, even though the wind was becoming more and more gusty. She didn't feel cold, neither from the ice nor from the wind. Even though her knees were raw, she felt no pain. Fortunately, she didn't feel hungry either. She could still feel that her teeth were sharp and elongated, as were her claws, including those at her feet. Finally she climbed onto a rock ledge to think for a while. Shogi Hung next to her, trying not to lean on the narrow stone ledge so as not to take up her space, but he rubbed against her comfortingly. She looked up at the sky, where a storm was brewing. Perhaps she should climb down and return to the Camp, but she couldn't bring herself to do that. At that moment, she wanted to sit here forever until the wind crushed these mountains. She heard several massive graves that seemed to hit quite nearby, though she saw no lightning anywhere. It was quite strange, And so many strange things have been happening lately... Strange and scary. Suddenly

she saw a falling star. She felt this might be the moment. She heard stories from the inhabitants of Icarus that shooting stars made wishes come true. She closed her eyes and asked for everything to be as before. To be normal again girl, and that there would be no war and everyone would live happily. For a split second she hoped that this had happened, that everything was fine. Then she opened her eyes and saw that the stars were still flying towards them. She realized that it was not a star, but some vehicle that hit the nearby hill hard, causing the entire slope to shake . She had to hold on to Shogi so as not to fall. She heard a short grunt and looked down. She saw Catra leaning towards her on the rock wall. She created an ice hook again, and extended her hand towards her feline friend to help her enter. Shogi He extended his tentacles towards Melog to give him a reason too. They dragged them both upstairs and Catra hugged her, not caring that she was only in blood-stained underwear and a shirt.

„Oh, it's so good that I found you!„ She moved away from her a bit and, furrowing her eyebrows, asked. „ Are you OK? You're covered in blood! Did someone hurt you? You're cold, we have to get you out of here or you'll freeze!„ There was a fear in her voice that she had never heard before from the fearless feline Warrior.

„I'm fine. I just... felt bad.„ she said and looked down, because she knew that she would soon have to face reality, terrible and terrifying.

„Listen to me. We have to go to the camp soon. There's a storm approaching, and there's a predator rampaging around. Adora is nearby. She will heal you with her power.„ said the cat girl excitedly, holding her shoulders, but she could only laugh bitterly.

„There is no predator here that could hurt me.„ She said quietly and looked into her friend's eyes. She felt tears streaming down her face. Much to her delight, she noticed Fear on Catra's face. She wiped her cheeks and saw that instead of tears, blood was flowing from your eyes. She didn't even have the strength to be scared.

„We'll help you. She-Ra revived Klementine , so curing you shouldn't be a problem.”

She felt sad because she didn't have the strength to tell her friend that what had happened to her couldn't be reversed, and certainly not like this, but she couldn't tell her that now. She was getting ready to go down when suddenly winged creatures burst into the air from where the spaceship had hit, and there was a loud flapping of wings, like giant dragonflies. They rushed towards them.

She tried to keep up with her wife while staying within Izai's sight , and the latter was much more difficult than that. The man was in good shape, but he couldn't keep up with someone like She-Ra. At first, she was skeptical of him, especially since he worked for someone like Lady Ka, but he seemed very composed and knew what he was doing. Then she remembered where she got that accent from. Kesler was the planet where those kids, the ones with Catra's sister, came from. She didn't know what to think about it. After all, the fact that someone came from same planet didn't mean anything. After all, Shadow Weaver was also from Etheria... But maybe she would learn something from him about what happened to that place... All she knew was that it was lost because the Swarm had come there. Maybe this way they will learn a way to persuade that girl... That Eti. Maybe if her wife focuses on the plan to free her sister, she will find something to focus and be calmer. She hadn't witnessed her descending into the depths of self-destructive anger during the war, but she had heard a lot about it from Scorpia's stories. Now she feared it was happening again. First Shadow Weaver's question, then her escape, and what happened to Frosta and Glimmer, and now what she told her about the Star Stone. Her father's arrival, and what his subordinates, especially Lady Sorrowflame, did didn't help, she wouldn't say it out loud, though perhaps she should. I'll have to talk about all this, but first they have to save Frosta, and that might not be that easy.

She didn't panic when she saw the dead animal. Whatever did it, Frosta should be able to deal with it, and even if she did, it was still Shogi , they both saw that it was truly an incredibly powerful being. She was more worried about whether the girl would freeze. She didn't know if she would be able to save her after something like that. Especially since the girl seemed to react badly to her touch.. She did n't understand why, but she was afraid it might mean something terrible... Just like her wife, she felt powerless.

She saw Catra climbing the rock wall. She wanted to help her, but then she saw something falling from the sky, like a meteor or something like that . However, as it got closer, she realized that it was something else... It looked a bit like a ship. She wasn't able to look at it because it was flying too fast and hit a nearby Hill.

„Catra! Be careful!„ she exclaimed, seeing that her wife was shaken by the shock wave caused by the falling ship, but Frosta grabbed her and pulled her up. She was about to join them when she heard the trapper's curses. She turned to him and saw that he had grabbed his gun and was staring at the place where the ship had hit.

„We're in trouble... I guess we'll soon find out if you're as good a warrior as everyone claims.„ his voice was gloomy and full of bitter stubbornness.

„What was that? What is this ship? Have you seen one like this before?„ she said, and Saihe looked towards her. She saw in his eyes the same mixture of despair and wrath that she saw in those who came from the planets ravaged by Horde Prime .

„It's the Swarm.„ He said firmly and cocked the gun. And then she heard a buzzing sound. Surprisingly loud, coming from the place where the ship hit. She saw some winged figures take to the air.

„Vaphormas.„ He said and tried to contact his command through the communicator, but due to the specifics of Dryl, he was unable to do so, So he cursed and ran in that direction.

„Wait! What about my wife and Frosta?„ she called, and Saihe didn't even turn to her when replied

„We have to give them some time to come down. On this ledge It is too tight for them to defend themselves.”

She nodded, for she understood the logic behind his words. She grabbed her sword with both hands and moved towards those creatures..

She was very happy that she had managed to find Frosta, even though she seemed to be in a bad condition. She was covered in blood and smelled of meat and something else she couldn't quite put her finger on. It seemed to her that something had happened to her face, although she wasn't sure what, and there was blood running from her eyes. it was very bad with her. However, Then the ice princess looked where the shockwave came from. She didn't look at what happened earlier because she was climbing and didn't have time to look at it. But now she saw that it was a spaceship that may not have completely crashed, but it definitely didn't land properly either. She saw his strange beings disappear, like great insects. Frosta cringed, then called out

„I do not like it! They are flying towards us! But they don't look friendly.”

The girl was right. These creatures were something that made her concerned, although she didn't like insectoids, so maybe she wasn't objective. But anyway, she decided it would be better if they went downstairs. She wanted to help Frosta , attacked by surprise and started to descend on her own as if nothing had happened to her. She moved down smoothly , even better than when they went to that buried city. In the distance she saw a brighter figure, her wife clearly eager to fight. That's why she loved her, for her unpretentious bravado bordering on stupidity. Together they jumped to the ground, and then doom came from the sky.

For that moment, as she charged at the enemy, she felt strangely calm, as if all her worries had flown away. She was in the heat of battle again, facing her enemy, and power pulsed in her veins. She grabbed the sword of protection with both hands, and jumped towards the creatures. There were many of them, at least a dozen or so. They were large, at least two meters long, and like all insects, six limbs. The large wings made a deafeningly loud buzzing sound. To her surprise, some of them had limbs transformed into rifles, but with a strangely organic appearance. Immediately, some of them flew towards them. Saihe started shooting with his energy weapon at the creatures and even hit two of them, which fell to the ground trailing plumes of smoke. At this time, she jumped towards them. She took a powerful swing and slashed at the monster, cutting it in half. Another creature jumped at her, trying to tear her apart, but her armor was strong enough to stop the impact. She fell to the ground, hitting the ground, causing a wave of dust. The Beasts began to surround her, so she performed a wide pirouette, knocking down several opponents. The Creatures moved away from her, giving her some space and being able to look around to assess the situation. She noticed Catra and Frosta slowly coming down, but they disappeared soon, probably because Melog used a cloaking field. At the same moment she felt something hit her armor. Some insects with these strange biological guns started shooting at them. In her case, the bullets were unable to penetrate the armor, but Izai had to constantly dodge to avoid getting hit. She saw that the projectiles were starting to move, it turned out that they were some large beetles that were now biting into one of the downed monsters. She aimed her Sword at it and then fired a beam of energy from it. She lost one of the creatures in the Swarm, and the others scattered. Then she saw another slightly smaller, butterfly-winged look at them and make a few gestures that looked disturbingly like casting a spell. For a moment she felt a slight pain, which quickly disappeared, but the trapper grabbed his For a moment she felt a slight pain, which disappeared immediately, but the trapper grabbed his head, and she saw blood

leaking from his eyes and ears. So these creatures could cast spells, did that mean they were intelligent and fully self-aware? She hesitated before continuing her attacks, but then one of them was hit by a block of ice, knocking him to the ground. It was her friends who reached them and joined the fight. Her wife jumped at another of the creatures, who wanted to land on her, without effort she tore him to shreds. Shogi shot out two tentacles, which caught the next creatures, crushing them. They continued fighting, chopping and shooting at the attackers. Frosta fought with a fury she had never seen in her before. She was only in a shirt and underwear, which were stained with blood, but she seemed to be fine. With her large icy claws, she smashed the beast one by one. They almost won, when suddenly what was left of the ship burst open, and a huge insectoid crawled out, twice as large as the others. However, one of its limbs ended in what looked like a curved crystal sword, and the other had a multitude of tiny tentacles that shot out toward its companions, trying to entwine them. With a scream, she jumped at him, but to her surprise, he blocked her sword strike with his own. He pushed her away but didn't even look her way, he just stared at Catra who was fighting with his mothers. She cut off two of them, but they started growing back immediately, and the next two are twining around the waist and pulled them towards the creature. She found herself right in front of his face. For a brief moment, she felt as if the creature was watching me, and she could have sworn she saw fascination in its eyes. Fortunately, it lasted a second and then the creature was hit by a beam of energy fired from Saihe's rifle . She took advantage of this moment and transformed her sword into a long spear, which she pierced the creature's chest. He let out a strange cry, as if full of disappointment, and then fell to the ground. He was the last one. Silence fell over the battlefield

„What was that?„ The ice princess asked, looking at the defeated opponents.

„They're Swarm monsters. I fought them on my home planet. I recognize some of them, but many are new varieties. I've never seen anything like this. „ He pointed to the creature with the crystal sword. „ I've never heard of you doing anything like that

either. They usually come in swarms, gigantic fleets capable of devour entire planets. I don't know, maybe they appeared somewhere else, but the arrival of the entire fleet would have been detected. It looks like a scouting party that was looking for something... „ Izai said and looked in her direction. She nodded because his theory made sense. She approached the corpse of the largest opponent and began to examine his blade. She had never seen a weapon that could block the strike of a sword of protection before. It's worth taking it to give it to Entrapta for examination once they liberateher. Catra walked up behind her, also looking at the creature anxiously, until suddenly, one of the other monsters, whom they had previously assumed was Dead, got up and wanted to jump at her, but then Frosta intercepted him and threw him to the ground. Long claws emerged from the girl's fingers and she dug into the creature's body, tearing its flesh as easily as Catra had done it with her claws earlier. Frosta turned towards them and breathed heavily. Now she saw that she was milky, had long claws, slightly pointier ears, and was almost certain that its teeth had become longer. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Saihe aiming his rifle at her.

„What are you doing! Put it down immediately! „ Catra approached the man, extending her claws. Izai gave her a quick look and said.

„Your friend becomes a Ghoul, a corpse-eating undead monster!” Saihe said in a serious voice.

„One more word and you'll end up like those creatures.„ her wife drawled, and she stood next to her.

„Frosta is our friend. If you do anything to her, even if you try, you will die. „ She said coldly and hard. Melog began to approach the man from behind, and Shogi grew, almost taking on his true form. Saihe he sighed and then lowered the gun.

„This is your decision, and you will have to accept the consequences of your mercy. „ He said coldly, but it didn't seem like he had any intention of fighting any further. They turned to

the ready princess. The girl with her head down. Catra took out the cloak that Frosta had discarded earlier and covered her with it.

„Everything will be fine. Don't worry, we will definitely find a way to help you. I promise!„ said her wife, but Frosta smiled painfully.

„You're a very good person Catra, you know that?„ she said quietly and together they went towards the camp.

Herold blinked, feeling the bond. She wagged her tail at what she saw. That person she saw brought back memories. They were from before she was born into the Swarm. She resembled someone she once knew. The person she liked. She felt off balance. For the first time since she had become part of the great community, she was Lost. So far everything has always been clear. Hunger had to be satisfied, nothing else mattered. Everything she did was dedicated to this. She had knowledge that she acquired in a terrible way. Now she had to use it for their good. The Swarm listened to her advice, even separating part of itself for her to manage. This was necessary to fulfill the new goal of the Swarm… But now something had changed. Until now, the future was like a dream, like a nightmare ... but now it's back! She didn't want it to be like that, because she was full of pain. But this person… Could it be her, one of them? She wasn't sure because she couldn't look at it. Her curiosity cost her the loss of her Enforcer. They were valuable, because the creation of their swords was expensive. They could only find this crystal in a few places, and most were out of their reach. However, this expedition yielded a lot of valuable information. She tested their enemy's skills. They learned his most dangerous weapon, and saw that the Crystal Blades were able to resist it... Now she just had to wait until they managed to implement the rest of their plan. So now she could rest a bit. So she went and looked for Her. She was waiting for her as always, ready to take her into her arms. They hugged her and she started humming a song, bringing her comfort,

Chapter End Notes

Well, I really like Frosta, but the plot led to these events. What do you think of the Herald? As always, I wholeheartedly welcome your comments and opinions.

The despair of the righteous and the hope of the wicked

Eti was glad that no one asked them too many questions. What happened in the undergrounds of Castle Crypto should remain a secret for now. She wasn't sure what to say about all this. A lot of things happened there, most of which she didn't understand. The fact that Blonde Boy turned out to be BLONDE GUY seemed the least of the problems. She liked him, and he seemed okay. Even if it turns out that he is her brother”in”law, she has nothing against it. It's important that he doesn't demand gifts from her for her birthday, because then he'll hit that yellow head with a metal hand. She didn't quite understand why he thought he should hide the fact that he could turn into this Big Guy. It seemed to have something to do with what happened when Her sister”in”law found that sword there. For all she knew, a lot of unpleasant things had happened back then. Everyone was trying to kill each other, especially her sister and her sister’s future wife, and almost blowing up half the universe, but trying the same things and expecting different results was the definition of wisdom... No, that was madness... But there was very little difference between wisdom and madness, she knew something about it. This time, however, the situation was different. Scar should be happy that her boyfriend was able to transform into someone like the heroine of the Galaxy. After all, she was at war with her father, any support would be useful to her... They should also be happy, she and her other boyfriend, for another reason. After all, the blonde boy was really big now... in every way. But she wasn't going to reveal his secret, he had to find out for himself. She didn't believe what the inquisitor said about him, she didn't care who built the sword and why, and neither did Golarion, who meant even less to her than Tarak. Unfortunately, she couldn't ignore the rest of the news so easily.

It was very cool to discover new possibilities of her hand. She hadn't wondered before why it was so valuable. She was sure it was just another ancient gadget that stupid, rich people collected. Yes, ithad taken some interesting abilities, but she knew well that the implants could do things quite similar. Of course, she liked her very much, and not only her, several of her girlfriends also found that its touch could be amazing. Now, however, she has discovered that it can change shape, and previously that she can throw energy bolts. She'll have to try out those abilities, and find out if it has any others. Unfortunately, she also learned something about herself and her family. She didn't fully understand it, but she didn't like being called an abomination at all. But her family was so twisted that it didn't make much of a difference.

But there was still Rosie... She had seen from that night in Brightmoon that she was hiding a secret. But most people had their secrets, she didn't mind. She loved her anyway. It didn't matter to her, but it mattered to the white”haired girl... The truth was overwhelming for ... Rosie was created by those who forged these swords and the weapons that were on this planet. Worst of all, they guessed why Rosie was created... She saw what she did when she met the Blondie in her second form. She almost killed her, it was close... She didn't mind that their girl was artificially created. After all, she herself was just a product for Jantar. What did it matter whether someone was given life by a woman or a machine? However, those behind it still controlled her. They still wanted her to be their tool... Their weapon, with which they could take revenge on their enemies... Including her sister and sister”in”law... She had absolutely no idea what she could do about it. Even fighting her father was beyond her capabilities. She was just a girl who knew best how to hurt others. She was good at killing, knew a little about warfare, and even about how rule people, though she never used these skills. She just wanted... to live and never be alone. She was not someone who could stand up to such power. She never wanted to fight ancient species and solve ancient puzzles. There was only Eti... but I guess she will have to become Eterna... She has to come up with something to

protect Rosie, she won't let her be taken away from her! But how is she supposed to do it?

Of course, they couldn't completely hide what happened in the underground from Scar. They didn't have to lie, they just didn't tell the whole truth. they simply said that in the underground they found an ancient droid that wanted to kill them but they managed to deal with it without much effort, but there may be other such machines in the underground, so let the other soldiers be careful and let Smarty examine the remains. Of course, they had to make sure that Smarty didn't talk about that all herself, but she decided to let her see their databases. Alatar has pirated so many TV series that she'll be busy in a few hours or so, and then I'll come up with something. You could say they're out of trouble for now. They also learned that they were leaving the castle soon. Maybe it's a good thing, she's seen nicer places on this planet. The captain Wingy was also heading out to meet her husband, who was that nice old man they met when they first came across Heart Gift. They would have to do something with that girl too, but she wasn't quite sure what. According to Rosie, they couldn't just leave her like that, they had to come up with something to help her deal with her loneliness and the fact that she had been deceived or manipulated. Well, it would be easier if she created a new body, and maybe they could somehow get her onto their ship, but they would have to talk to Mr. Ilemshaw about that, since he was the one piloting the ship now. Bina will definitely agree, another kid won't bother her.

Her uncle wasn't causing any problems for now, so she left him alone. She knew she was risking a lot by letting him live, but he still saved her when she was Jantar's prisoner. She owed him so much, even though she knew that he didn't help her out of the goodness of his heart, because it was forged of cold iron. But he was still better than her father, if only by a little. She could only hope that he would not seek revenge for his lost power.

So she lay on her back, staring at the cafeteria ceiling, from where quite pleasant smells were coming. Wrongdak and Lilka were a really good pair of cooks. Everyone was preparing for the

expedition north, a skeleton crew would remain in the castle, which was to surrender in the event of a more serious attack, and the rest were to either fly with the Comrade General or go to the mountains, together with all the equipment, and wait for further orders. The plan actually sounded good. They were supposed to be looking for some ancient ship, so maybe they should contact Heart Gift somehow. She just has to tell it in a way that Lonnie can understand. Only she is of course completely unfamiliar with conveying such things. She would most like to simply say that they have made friends with an ancient artificial intelligence that is a bit depressed but generally trustworthy, provided I try to kill everyone on the planet again, which she has already tried to do once but managed to talk her out of. That probably wouldn't sound good... She really needs to learn how to convey information to people without scaring them. Being nice to others is much harder than breaking their bones. While she was thinking, Rosie came to her and lay down next to her, cuddling her.

„How do you feel?„ she asked in sign language, getting up on her knees so that the girl could see her. The white-haired woman smiled sadly and said.

"It's hard to describe. Until now, I thought I was just an orphan who had the misfortune of getting caught up in events that were beyond her. I wanted to go on adventures, but I never thought it was so difficult. But now it's worse. Everything I knew about myself… everything I thought I knew about myself, turned out to be a lie. I was created as a weapon, as a killer. I was going to kill someone good, you saw it yourself. Now it's all clear. Even if I don't know exactly who I am, I know that I was created for the wrong purpose.„ her girlfriend She lowered her head, saddened. So she stood up a little, awkwardly hugged her, and then said.

„I'll be there with you. When I'm with you, I can hold back, remember. I just touched you and I was able to bring you back to consciousness. Next time it will work too, or maybe there won't be a next time... For now, what happens to you only when you are close to the BLONDE... Close to She-Ra. We'll just make sure you're never near her while she's turned and everything will be

fine. You talked to her on Icarus and you didn't want to kill her, did you?„ She looked straight into her bright blue eyes, gentle but also full of depth. She kissed her, but Rosie then pulled away and continued to explain her concerns.

„What if that's not all? What if I have to do something else terrible? I don't know... Rebuild this heart or something like that... „ she looked straight into her eyes.„ Then... Will you stop me? In whatever way is necessary…”

She understood the unspoken request hidden in those words. For a moment the fire in her heart went out, and then it flared up with a hundredfold strength.

„I will do what you ask me... If it is necessary... „ she said quietly, and added in her thoughts. *And then I will set the Galaxy on fire*.

„You really did it, Mr. Wrongdak. I've never seen such a beautiful Orc Apple Pie!„ Lilka exclaimed with delight.

„Me too.„ he answered her truthfully. He knew absolutely nothing about Orc baking or Orc cuisine, but he tried his best to prepare the cake according to the red-haired girl's instructions. Emily helped them by carrying cakes and ingredients to make them. He liked his job as a cook because it reminded him of one of the first things he did after he was released. Even when he was among the Skittermanders, he liked trying new foods, but preparing them for others was much more interesting. He could make others' lives better, happier. On the one hand, it didn't require much sacrifice of time, on the other hand, the art of cooking made him feel creative. When he was part of the Horde, the mere thought of eating normal food instead of previously prepared amino acids and proteins was forbidden. This was yet another way he could oppose Horde Prime’a even after his death. Plus, cooking allowed him to take his mind off his worries.

He knew he should be happy that Shadow Weaver had left them and that Catra had found her father. Except this He knew he had hired Graag, the person who had enslaved him, to sell him as a thing. Lady Ka had imprisoned Itel, and was ready to kill her if necessary. She had even shot at Entrapta, who disliked violence so much. He was glad his friend was with them, and that his brother was not mad at him. Entrapta could help solve many of their problems, though he did not know how yet, but she was so smart that she would surely think of something.

Now they were slowly packing up to head north. Along with the soldiers serving Eti... and Catra's uncle. He didn't like the feline man either. The people of his race, or species as they were known in the galaxy, hadn't always been so warlike. He saw something of Catra in Igzar, and in Eti as well, a similar determination and barely restrained rage... Only the old mercenary was much more calculating and cunning. He had heard that Eti had intimidated him in some way, but he wasn't sure how. Anyway, deep down he hoped that this Pahtra would understand that not everyone was his enemy. So now I'm trying to use the last moments of my stay in this castle and cook for my friends.

„Can I have a word?„ someone called from the entrance to the kitchen. When he looked that way, he saw Bina smiling at him. He bowed to her and said.

„If Lilka agrees to let me stop cooking, I'll be happy to talk...„ he said, smiling at the burgund-haired womenh. He liked her, if only because I took such good care of Eti and the rest of the kids...

„Sure Bina! Emiliy and I can handle it!„ Lilka exclaimed, smiling at him. He smiled at her in response and followed the captain. She led him to one of the low and lonely towers that so numerously decorated the castle.

„What did you want to ask me?„ he said, a bit concerned. She probably had reasons to be angry with him. After all, he didn't recognize Shadow Weaver while she was traveling with them.

“I've heard your kind can't lie, and you certainly can't, as I've come to realize in my weeks of traveling. So tell me, did this woman, Shadow Weaver, do anything to my children? They say she didn't, but they can hide it. You yourself have noticed that they always try to pretend to be stronger than they are.”

He thought for a moment and then shook his head.

„She didn't do anything, I don't think she even raised her voice again, I must admit that they were probably the ones who got themselves into trouble. And her too. She… had a friend … girl, I mean. Or a woman… you know what I mean… And I guess they're broken up now. Because she had to reveal herself when she saved Eti... Then she found a home for them here. I didn't know her before, I only met her once and I never talked to her. I saw the effects of what she did. How she hurt them, her daughters. I know what wounds she inflicted on them because I received similar ones from my Big Brother.„ A much shorter woman straight into the eyes. She squinted and sighed heavily.

„I'm happy about it. That means she didn't do anything to them. I was raised in similarly terrible conditions, by an individual who saw me as just a tool, an extension of his will. Part of me wants her to rot in the dungeon, have her head cut off or whatever you do with criminals here... But on the other hand, she saved Eti Twice, or rather thrice, if you count the fact that she didn't let her be captured by her father. And she sacrificed herself to save Itel... It would be much easier if she was just a nasty hag that could simply be left behind and forgotten. Now I feel a bit like I betrayed her.”

He thought for a moment before answering.

„It's more complicated. Catra…She also did a lot of bad things, hurt a lot of people. Not to mention my brother who... He destroyed the lives of an entire generation... I know that I would also do evil if my friends had not freed me. Sometimes it's just hard to separate the bad from the good. I lived for some time on a planet conquered by the Vesks. They are warriors who love to

wage war, even though it is known that it is associated with great evil. They are brave and honorable, they accepted me, they do not ask what I am or where I come from. But I know that their leaders are no different from my brother, only that they had a choice, their minds were not warped by conditioning. They could choose. Same with Eti’s Uncle... She says he saved her, but he is also belligerent and ruthless... I guess most people are like that...”

The woman smiled friendly at him. It was a very nice and pleasant smile.

„You're quite smart for an eight-year-old.„ She laughed briefly and added. „Or rather, you're just smart, honest and good-hearted but that's not a flaw. It's better to be someone like that, you know, someone like Lady Cala'i... I didn't like her from the beginning. I should have trusted Eti's instincts. The girl sensed who she was. She pursed her lips angrily. He himself was fooled by that girl. She seemed so wonderful, beautiful and smart. She was perfect, but Entrapta said imperfection was beautiful. Did this start to make such perfection terrible? Inhuman? He didn't know the answer to that question.

„By the way , if we're going north, you're going to need some new clothes. You can borrow them from us. If you want, I'll help you put them on. „ she said and winked at him. He frowned, what did she mean?

Lady Sorrowflame stretched her back. A long journey awaited... Maybe not that long, but lonely and perhaps in the light of moons... The bright ones that burned like the sun. She had some protection, and having them come anyway weakened her. Still, this journey was worth every sacrifice. She had to get to Umbracor, she had to find out the truth. She was almost sure that the strange elflike creature was telling the truth. It was too time-consuming to deceive her about this , and it didn't bring them any profit. Perhaps they wanted to use her power to break the security of this place, but that was rather unlikely. And even if

they wanted to, well, he joined the countless legions of fools who wanted to take advantage of her. However, if they were telling the truth and finally, after all these centuries, she would discover What happened to Golarion... A shiver of excitement shook her cold, dead body, something she hadn't felt for a long time! Now she finally understood that she was destined to come to this place! It was not a matter of chance, but the Will of higher forces that wanted her to discover the truth! Her faith, which had smoldered like an ember covered with ashes for centuries, was now ready to burst into flame! A flame that will set the universe on fire! But one thing at a time, he has to get there first.

„ They're still looking for the girl... I wonder what happened to her? It would be very funny if she froze in a storm! Frozen Frosta! I guess this is called pure irony.” Lady Ka giggled at her own joke. It may not have been the best, but she had to admit it was quite funny.

„Don't say things like that out loud. Someone might hear, and you're not very popular here anyway. Remember that when I leave, you will be on your own here.„ She said seriously, looking at the Lord Admiral's left hand. They stood here, away from the rest of Jaki's army, which was preparing to lay siege to the rebel castle. Well, as it turned out, neither the Dark Sorceress nor the monstrous aristocrat were there, but of course they weren't going to tell anyone about it. Still, they had to be ready to fulfill Antares's orders. The problem was that these orders could turn out to be contrary to the wishes of the queen and her friends. Unfortunately, even if she wanted to, her options were limited. She was powerful, but such a delicate matter required a bit of finesse, and she always lacked patience for such matters. Perhaps her hypnotic abilities would allow her to capture the second daughter, but the destruction she could wreak would further inflame relations between the fleet and the monarchy, and it was not yet time to depose Glimmer from the throne and give it to the Grand Marshal. . However Lady Ka had a very personal attitude towards the capture of that girl. She had to be careful, and her petty hatred towards that girl would cause her to lose control and anger the Lord Admiral once again. She turned and looked at the

woman's hand, proof that it was not wise to cross him. Truth be told, she was lucky anyway, if she were Antares, she would have cut off both her arms and legs. But she wasn't in his place as far as she knew, she never had any real offspring or Family, even before her transformation.

„Will this storm bother you?„ the woman in the half-mask said to her. She smiled at her.

„Close to where I lived, just before she became undead, there was a gigantic storm that raged for centuries, but it didn't keep me away, and neither will this storm.„ she reassured her companion.

„ And if the Lord Admiral's heiress got lost in this storm and was never found, it would be an irreparable loss, but we could not prevent it in any way, so sad „ Lady. Ka She laughed quietly, but answered her with full seriousness.

"You should give up on your dislike towards Catra. If you are unable to accept that in the future she will take over the legacy of the Antares family, then look for a new patron. With your skills, it probably wouldn't be that difficult. „ she said in a hard tone, and the woman in the half-mask sighed heavily.

„It's easy for you to say. You are an ancient dragon and vampire. You changed patrons more times than I changed knives. A I like to change knives. „ To emphasize her words, she threw up one of the knives and caught it in the air. „I'm not used to this."

She turned to her and kissed Lady Ka.

In fact, you are right, and at the same time you are so wrong. I have worked with many people, but my one true patron was Dahak. „ she moved away from her and smiled similarly. „ I'll try to find a new place for you, my dear. „ She said and, taking off her clothes, she transformed into a dragon, spread her wings and flew in the direction where she was supposed to find answers to the secrets that had been haunting her for centuries.

Words that hurt like knives - Part one

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

„You see? We are already there! You'll go to bed soon and we'll prepare something warm for you! Catra said to her in a comforting tone. She smiled back, but she felt no Joy. For a brief moment after that fight, she was sure that everything would be back to normal. And then the Man told who she was, what was happening to her. This infuriated Catra, who now assured her that it was all nonsense, that nothing was happening, she just needed to be cured!”

She didn't deny that because she didn't to upset her friend even more, she already seemed to be shaken. But she knew he was telling the truth. She was turning into a monster, a terrible creature from the legends told during snowstorms. Both Shogi and Melog seemed concerned about this, though each for different reasons. The multi-eyed ancient creature was worried about the health of its mistress, while the immigrant from a distant planet clearly wanted to reassure his companion, but it was not easy.

They reached the camp, where everyone greeted them joyfully. Under any other circumstances, she would have been ashamed of having caused so much trouble, but now she saw that her problems were not over. That she would have to face. After their first greetings, they saw the queen's tent flaps begin to open, and Glimmer and Bow ran out. The Queen still couldn't teleport, so things weren't quite right for her either. They both ran to her and wanted to hug her, but she stepped back and pulled her hood tighter. Glimmer stood in front of her confused and her husband asked.

“Are you okay? If something happened then…” he asked, holding out his hand to her, but she pulled away, and Catra said.

“Frosta is tired, a lot has happened and I think we need to talk about a few things… - she was very serious, so everyone nodded in agreement. But let Frosta rest in her tent for a while, after what happened… All this tired her out a lot.”

„Hey! I'm just here, don't talk about me like I'm not here!” She looked sharply at her feline friend, who nodded

„You're right, sorry. „ She said in an apologetic tone. „ Is everything okay with you? „ Catra looked at Glimmer, who hesitated.

„Yes, apart from the fact that I can't still use my power.„ The Queen rubbed her shoulder. „My hand is just a little numb, but it's nothing serious.”

„Will I also be able to participate in this council?” Saihe asked in a cautious voice.

„So you can spread nonsense again!„ the feline woman looked sharply at the soldier, but her wife put a hand on her shoulder, so the Grand Marshal calmed down a bit.

„I'm very sorry about what happened, but unfortunately I have to discuss a few things. Very important things.” Saihe gave them a look that made even Bow look gloomy .

„Okay, let's go to the command tent. And so it would be useful for us to talk about the strategy for the coming days.„ said Glimmer and started giving orders. However, after a while, a messenger ran up to them and saluted. He was wearing the strange armor worn by soldiers serving the Star Sisters. The color red indicated that it served Halo

„I'm sorry, Queen, but Halo, The Star Sister would like to talk to you about a very urgent matter that I'm sure she'll be interested in.„ he said in an official tone.

„I'm very sorry, but ask her if she could wait, because we need to urgently discuss matters of state importance. „ the queen explained, looking at him apologetically, but then they heard a vague and rough voice from behind the guard.

„Oh, I won't take up too much of your time... „ The crowd that was slowly gathering around them parted and she saw a woman sitting in a wheelchair who had blue hair and her body on the right side was grayish, as if dead. She was surrounded by blue" armored guards, and accompanied by a liveried Horde Clone who supported her wheelchair behind her. She knew this woman well.

„Aunt Hello! „ she called happily and took a few steps towards the woman, but her guards covered her.

„ Good morning Frosta . I just came here to talk about your situation. „ she said in a gentle, almost motherly tone and smiled with the living half of her mouth.

"Maybe it's better that we go to a secluded place and discuss everything in private?„ Glimmer asked, but Halo laughed bitterly and hoarsely.

„Unfortunately, it will be best if everyone interested witnesses what will be said here. Some things shouldn't be hidden from the public, right?„ the woman looked at da Glimmer, and a strange spark appeared in her only seeing eye. Catra Grimaced at the Star Sister, Adora seemed confused at the sight of the woman. Bow, on the other hand, looked at the disabled woman with compassion.

„I don't know what you're talking about.„ Glimmer said with a little hesitation, as if Halo was right, she was hiding something. But the queen was always honest with her. At this moment, Netosa began to break through , followed by Mermista, who gave Star Sister a suspicious look, their kingdoms have never liked each other.

„Halo! Have you decided to join us now? That's good, any help is needed.„ said the general, holding on helplessly and smiling

happily.

„Unfortunately, that's not why I came here.„ the woman seemed a bit amused.

„But you know Shadow Weaver could be there... It turns out you were right and she's alive. Don't you want revenge? „ The ruler of Armoria asked , but Halo smiled mysteriously and nastily.

„Revenge, indeed, nothing tastes as sweet as revenge, but to really feel it you need... Some preparations. It's my business anyway, not your! I'm on my way to getting my justice, but you never had a hand in it. You only ever told me that she was dead and that I should move on with my life. And yet the truth came to light…. And now it's up to me to bring justice. I prepared everything myself, I took the reins of my destiny myself. But I didn't come here to talk about this Woman. What I want to talk about, unfortunately, touches on much sadder matters.„ she looked at her and saw sadness and a sense of guilt in her only healthy eye.

But after a moment, Her gaze hardened and she looked at Glimmer.

„Maybe not everyone knows this, but Princess Frosta had a terrible accident some time ago... Fortunately , she managed to recover, and now she is here with us... Or at least that's what everyone thought... But the truth is completely different, isn't Frosta?„ the woman in the wheelchair looked at her. Everyone around them did the same, even Netossa. She shuddered and pulled her hood tighter over her head.

„ Auntie Hello... Why are you doing this... You have always been good to me... Why do you want everyone to see now... It's not my fault! I didn't do anything wrong!„ she felt tears coming to her eyes again, and she couldn't let them flow down her face again. Not now, with everyone looking at her. Shogi walked up to her and tried to shield her from the eyes of those surrounding her

„ Leave her! She didn't do anything to you! What's happening to her doesn't concern anyone here! If you can't help her, leave her alone!„ Catra shouted furiously, but the woman with a half-paralyzed body smiled at the great Marshal.

„Of course she didn't do anything, and she's just a victim. Just like all of you, like Hordak, who was conditioned by his creator-brother and didn't want to conquer us all, or like you Catra, who was just a wronged girl, and the fact that you almost didn't kill us all was the result that no one understood you.”

„How dare you accuse her of what she once did. You know well that we stood together against Horde Prime . „ Adora said sharply, and the light shone in her blue eyes

„I don't know what you're talking about, but if you're going against my friend, you're going against me, too. Are you sure you want to do this?„ Glimmer She gave her a warning look, but Halo just smacked her lips indistinctly.

„I guess they haven't told you yet, have they? At least not everything. Even though I only found out about this matter recently, from a highly trusted source. If you want to know the truth, ask your friend to take off her hood. It's nothing difficult. Let me show you all what she looks like now. I'm not ashamed of what I am and what was done to me, so she should be too. „ she said quietly, smiling slightly. Glimmer looked at her as if to tell her to raise her hood, but then hesitated and looked at the rest of her friends questioningly.

„You're horrible„ Catra drawled, stretching her claws. Adora also stepped forward, sword in hand and glaring at the guards.

„What do you want from her?! Did you come here just to make her suffer even more? Anyone, but you know best what Shadow Weaver magic can do. „ She said firmly, but Star Sister laughed painfully.

“Just so you know, I know, but now I'm just asking the girl to take off her hood. Nothing bad will happen then, right?” She replied to the heroine of the Galaxy, and a mocking glint appeared in her eye. People started to look at them, and also whisper among themselves. Catra wanted to say something, which probably only made the situation worse, so she stepped forward and pulled off her hood. Everyone, including Glimmer took a deep breath. She lowered her gaze, fully aware of the impression she must have made. And still, no one knew the truth about what she really was.

“She's right, something terrible happened to me and I have no idea what. - She said in a hushed voice. She wanted to cringe, seeing the looks of everyone around her. But she raised her head and looked into Halo's eyes, both dead and alive.

„I, I don't know what happened to me. Shadow Weaver hit me with a Spell that put me in a coma. I was... I dreamed strange things... This dream was like a real one, and something happened there, something terrible. There I met first a terrifying woman and then this man. He touched me, and then I felt something. Since then I have changed, and today I have become what you see. I went into the Wild to hunt something because I was so hungry. I killed an animal and ate its flesh. I'm not sure what's happening to me, but it's definitely not good. Halo is right, he deserves you for a bit of truth, as much as I can tell you. I'm sorry if you feel bad that you were immediately informed about what happened to me and that I caused so much trouble for everyone.„ She looked down and wanted to hide somewhere. Glimmer looked at her with concern and fear in her eyes, Netossa stiffened, and Bow placed a hand on her shoulder, but she pulled away. Netossa stiffened, and Bow put a hand on her shoulder, but she moved away. She didn't want that kind of pity because it wasn't something others could help her with.

„Is... is there anything we can do for you?„ The techmaster said in a concerned voice, and she was about to answer him, but Catra interrupted.

„Of course we can! The power of She-Ra can definitely help you. After all, we've all seen what she can do. She healed me once... She brought me back from the dead! I've never talked about it before, but it was true. It shouldn't be the slightest bit difficult to cure her. We simply have to work out how to do it, but it's only a matter of time, nothing more.„ there was so much certainty] in her voice that she might be right, and for a moment she felt a surge of hope, but then Halo burst into loud, mocking laughter that echoed over the entire military camp, and the thunder of the approaching storm seemed to accompany it.

„Sweet children of innocent ignorance You know so little of the higher secrets that the universe holds. No child, She-Ra's power will not help you in any way. Well, not like that, at least in a way all wanted. For her power belongs to life, and you were touched by the forces of death itself. The man you saw was Charon himself, the leader of the daemons, the ruler of Abbadon , the Horseman Of Death, whom I chose as my patron!„ the woman rose in a wheelchair and showed a symbol depicting a skull with coins in place of the eye sockets. Most of the crowd looked on with confusion, but Saihe hissed and then made a strange gesture, reminiscent of what the inhabitants of her kingdom did to ward off evil spirits.

„What... what does that mean?„ she asked, looking fearfully at the woman she had considered her aunt for many years, whom she could always trust, and who now acted as if she was her greatest enemy.

„Your body is changing, or rather It is dying... You are slowly turning into a monster, not-dead monster. You become a Strigoi, a Ghoul-like creature that devours the flesh of other creatures, capable of tearing apart almost any ordinary animal. So you will be a monster that will arouse fear among the Inhabitants of this planet. However, there is a chance for you, because you have been offered grace... You will not change into this creature right away. It will take some time. You will be able to satisfy your hunger with raw meat for some time. This may take quite a long time, and it will seem to you that you rule over everyone...

Unfortunately, this is only an appearance, sooner or later your nature will reveal itself, and then you will become a threat to everyone, especially considering the power you have. There are several solutions, the simplest is most drastic, but also the safest.„ Halo paused for a moment so that everyone could understand what I was proposing... There was silence as everyone understood the implications of Sister Star's words.

„How can you even suggest such a thing!„ Glimmer shouted, and Catra jumped with her claws towards the Woman in the Wheelchair, but she raised her living arm and clenched her fist. The cat girl doubled over as if she was overcome by unbearable pain. But then Adora pointed your sword at her and it glowed with Rainbow light, making Halo cringe, and released Catra from her embrace. Bow drew his bow and aimed an arrow at the woman's chest.

„One more word, one move of your hand, and I will destroy you. I see that this light hurts you. I've heard that you are powerful, but if you continue to harm my loved ones, all your power will be useless!.„ Said the Princess of Power in an absolutely cold tone, and Sister Star cringed. Unfortunately, she was also pierced by the pain caused by the luminous power. Catra rose to her feet, her companion radiating blood red. It even seemed that the Great Marshal would like to attack Halo again, who laughed despite the pain that was gripping her.

„Well, after all, you serve life, don't you? I'm a half-dead cripple who just wants a little justice. Indeed, We stand on opposite sides...„ Star Sister said quietly, Ignoring the suffering.

„ Don't try to play the victim! It was you who came here and... „ Adora said, threatening the woman with her sword, so the guards drew their weapons, ready to fight the heroine of the Galaxy, but their mistress signaled them to hold back, and then she said in an amused voice.

„And what did I do? I only said a few words of truth, and there is nothing greater than the truth, isn't it?„ She looked at the shining

girl. Now it was clear how different they were. A woman broken by suffering, and a young heroine with a wonderful future ahead of her. But she herself couldn't bear it, just like Halo, she was also hurt by She-Ra's brightness . But the pain would be too great. She said in a whisper.

„Adora, please!„ but her friend didn't hear her, because the people gathered around started whispering among themselves, increasingly confused by the situation. Then Shogi wanted to help her and grew, taking on his true form. He pushed Adora , knocking her to the ground. When She-Ra was moved away from her She could breathe and she cried out.

„It hurts so much, please stop!„ she said through bloody tears. Adora turned to her, then dimmed her glow, but didn't completely dull it. Scrrams rang out as everyone saw Shogi's true form , even some took up weapons, ready to fight the monster.

„Shogi , everything's fine now!„ she said to her friend, who stepped back and looked at her questioningly. Catra, Adora and Netossa they knew what Shogoth looked like , but for the rest it must have been a terrifying sight. Glimmer's eyes widened, clearly shocked, and Bow went to cover her, but he stepped back when Glimmer looked at him and shook her head.

„Truly, another legend walks among us. Although it must be admitted that this is not a legend that anyone would like to meet on their journey. However, I think you both will make a great company.„ Said Halo calmly, who was obviously not very scared by the sight of the multi-eyed creature. „But think that you will intimidate me... „ She looked at Catra , who was panting heavily and staring at Star Sister with fury in her eyes. „You can try to kill me, and you would probably succeed, although I promise that it would not be easy for you to defeat me. But you are not the ones who would raise your hand against the messenger! But that's all I am!„ she laughed again. „However, I came here not only to open your eyes, but also because I know how to help Frosta. We promised a long time ago that we would take care of you, me and my sister! However, you are already an adult and you should be

able to cope on your own... But I can't just abandon you like that. So, I'll tell you a secret, but in return, your friends should give me something.„ She looked at everyone gathered. Many seemed very confused by Sister Star's words, but everyone waited to hear what the princesses and the great Marshal would say.

„Tell us what you want and what you can offer us!„ Glimmer said, looking at her carefully.

„I only want one thing, a spaceship. Specifically, Darla, the one you discovered in the desert. „ she said, looking at the queen with a half-smile. Glimmer, Adora and Catra looked shocked. It was actually the only remnant of Mara, the previous She-Ra... She was extremely important to Adora... And Entrapta ...”

„And what do you offer in return?„ Glimmer asked after several long moments of tense Silence. A triumphant smile appeared on Halo's face

„Few would be able to reverse the curse cast by Charon himself... Not even Another God could do it. But there are beings in the universe who can do this... Far away, there is a place known as Xadia where a sorcerer lives, powerful and wise. Only he has the knowledge to correct the Curse cast by my master. If you comply with my demands, I am ready to show you where to find this sorcerer. I guess your friend's life is worth more than one spaceship, right?„ she tilted her head and raised one eyebrow questioningly. All the princesses looked at each other, considering the wheelchair woman's proposal. The final decision belonged to only two people.

„How do we know you're telling the truth? „ asked the queen, looking carefully at the ashenfaced woman, who shook her head.

„You can't know if I'm telling the truth, but risk the future and happiness of one of you? „ Hello looked first at da Glimmer and then at her.

Why your Patron can't break the curse he made himself, but allows you to help break it. „ Adora asked sharply, and Halo no shrugged with one shoulder.

„ Horseman of Death will is unknown to mortals. He has his own purposes, which he may or may not reveal to me. Even if he did, it doesn't mean I would want to share them with you. Or maybe I just have scruples and want to help Frosta, Or maybe I calculated everything, and it's all part of the grand plan? You can't know that and let's be honest, it's not the most important thing.„ Said the Star Sister in a matter-of-fact tone, like a hunter selling pelts at the market.

„You will receive the answer in the evening! We still need to confer.„ Glimmer said in a serious voice. „But no matter what decision I make, you are not welcome in this kingdom.”

„Don't argue with her. She wants to deceive us all. It would be best if we imprisoned her and I had a serious talk with her. The old fashioned way...„ Catra said, giving Halo a menacing look.

Well, you remain a Horde Member forever.„ Halo said, smiling at the feline woman.

„After all, you yourself called me a pupil of Shadow Weaver.„ The Grand Marshal replied. The Star Sister snorted and told her clone to turn around and they started walking towards their means of transport, but then Catra called out.

„You know what? You became the one who ruined your life, like Shadow Weave .”

Halo then signaled the clone to stop and turn towards the great Marshal.

„You see, in life, as they say, it's better to die a hero than to live and become a villain.„ said the woman in the wheelchair and looked at Adora . „ I advise you and your loved one to think about these words.„ and left them alone.

v

Chapter End Notes

Sorry you had to wait so long for this chapter, but I was away and my dog had crossed the rainbow bridge.

Words that hurt like knives - part two

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She sat in the meeting and rubbed her temples with her fingers. She had just listened to Saihe and Catra and Adora's story about what happened when they were looking for Frosta. Another problem, another threat they had to face. Netossa and Mermista, as well as several minor commanders, were also present. They haven't informed Lady Ka or Lady Sorrowflame yet although this terrible woman apparently flew away to take care of some matters. She didn't think to forbid her from doing so and now it was too late, so she would have to come to terms with all the consequences that might result from what the Not-Dead dragon would do, although she probably wouldn't listen to her anyway. She wasn't sure she had any power over someone like that. Now they had to quickly confer about what had happened to Adora, Catra, and Frosta during the Search for the Ice Princess.

"So no further groups of these creatures have been detected reaching our planet?„ She finally asked, looking at Netossa and Onyx Sky, but they both shook their heads, and then the general spoke up.

"I don't know anything about that, I would have been notified if any had entered our planet's orbit." she said in a resigned tone, but then Onyx Sky spoke up. "I sent a query to space defense. They are examining the indications of the reconnaissance systems, but so far it seems that no aliens have reached our planet, or even the part of the former Empire that we control.

"But we didn't find out about the arrival of this ship before it was too late?" she asked with concern in her voice.

“Actually, this ship was detected, we just mistook it for a regular civilian vehicle. You gave the order not to stop every vehicle that arrived on this planet. “Said the person from Ikarus. Onyx Sky decided to stay with them despite the fact that General Juliette was stripped of her position and everyone knew that their very close relationship involved them.

„Well, then, I guess I'll have to change my orders.„ She sighed, because she did not like the increased isolation of Etheria and the closing of its borders.. She didn't want everyone who wanted to come here to be detained, because many of them were refugees looking for a better life on a planet not ravaged by war. However, if it may pose a threat to those who already live here, it will have to think about a better solution. „Do such troops herald an invasion? „ she looked at Izai, who carefully shook his head.

„I'm not sure if I'm the best person to comment on this, as I'm just an ordinary soldier who has simply faced these creatures in a few battles, but as far as I know, they don't have to worry about this type of thing. It is said that the Swarm is one gigantic organism, and its individual components are worth less to it than the hair on our head. The swarm simply sends out a fleet, and if it is repelled it either sends twice the size, or it doesn't. No one is really behind its Intentions. Honestly, it's better to ask someone more experienced, and who will give an opinion from a more... global or even cosmic perspective.„ He spoke carefully, but sounded reasonable.

„I know, that's why I sent it to someone else. We just have to wait a little longer.„ she said, but she also felt a little reassured. Soon the person she called entered the tent and bowed low to her.

„Good evening Majesty, I heard Why did you call me. I hope I can give you advice and share my knowledge.„ Asindesa di Vir said in an absolutely serious voice. She looked definitely worse than the last time she saw her. Her hair was messy and there were dark circles under her eyes. She was pale and emaciated, and was visibly depressed.

„You asked her for help! You know who she was hanging out with! We all know, and we always knew, but we didn't say it out loud... You had something in common with that witch! Let me tell you straight, you were lovers, or even more. You were one of the last people to talk to Shadow Weaver before She escaped. I'm not sure if you helped her escape from her cell, but we can't rule it out. Tell me why we shouldn't arrest you, actually I'm not sure why we haven't already!„ exclaimed the cat-like woman, looking menacingly at the knight, who accepted her words unmoved.

„Catra! We can't arrest just on suspicion!„ she turned to the Grand Marshal, who was about to answer her something sharply, but Asindesa interfered.

„Some of your suspicions are right. In fact, our relationship went far beyond friendship. However, she had no idea who she really was, even though I knew she dealt in dark magic, but that was nothing that would be considered shocking to us Hell Knights. Many of us summon devils or practice necromancy. I had no reason to suspect she came from this planet, mind you, it was completely unknown to the wider universe for millennia! To be honest, I could and should have been more vigilant, which is why I would like to compensate for my shortcomings before I submit myself to the order's court. The sentence will be severe, but it is not your business, but the Order's. Until then, I can serve you and try to correct my mistakes.„ she was speaking seriously all the time, although she also had the impression that she could sense resignation and great sadness in her voice, but she seemed to be sincere, so she decided that she could trust her.

„If you are ready to follow my orders, I agree to accept temporary service, but remember who you may meet along the way. I'm not sure how much I can trust that you will make the right decision then. To be honest, we here understand all too well what you must be going through right now. „ she looked significantly at Catra, who snorted irritably. The knight pulled out her sword, the strange one that always caught Adora's eye.

„I swear on my honor, and also on the honor of My Order, that I will serve you faithfully, I will not betray you in any way, and I will do everything... Absolutely everything to correct my mistakes. „She said, kneeling down and stabbing the blade into the ground beneath their feet. They looked at each other, but she had already decided.

„I accept your oath, but I called you here for a completely different reason. I want to talk to you about the Swarm... „ she said, and then Asindesa looked at her with fear in her eyes.

„Does this mean you are at risk of invasion?„ She asked , looking at the Queen anxiously. She explained to her what had happened, repeating the words of Izai, who sometimes corrected her. The Hellnight nodded her head while listening to this account and finally said.

„This looks different than I expected. It didn't have to be an invasion, because it looked like some sort of reconnaissance mission. I have fought many enemies, cultists of Great Old One's , the Dominion of Black, but the Swarm battles have always been the hardest. However, this is an opponent without subtlety. At least that has been the case so far, because the Swarm can adapt to the opponent and the methods used by him. This is not an ordinary enemy, but one great orgasm, thousands of components united by one will, one. awareness." The Knight explained, and the Saihe soldier confirmed her words with a nod. „This behavior is so unusual that I honestly don't know what to say about it. However, I know that there are many treasures hidden behind your planet. You know it too...„ The knight looked at them significantly, so she sighed and replied.

„The legacy of the First Ones is a real curse for our planet.„ She looked at Adora apologetically, but the heroine of the Galaxy just nodded and smiled, showing that she understood. „However, should we prepare for further incursions of this type?„ she looked the knight straight in the eyes, and she sighed heavily and said.

„Probably yes, but they may be larger than this onee, although I'm not sure about that. This is a completely new way of doing things that we haven't found before. Perhaps the great Marshal's father could teach your captains to better guard the orbit, because where are you the best at it, No offense. „ she looked at the gathered commanders. Netossa nodded sadly and Mermista sighed and said smiling sadly.

„My husband would love to become the captain of a space ship, but he is slightly claustrophobic and hates computers and other similar devices. Besides, spaceships cannot be set on fire."

„That's a great idea! We have to inform my father about everything so that he can see him. I'm sure he'll be happy to help us!„ Catra exclaimed with such faith in the Lord Admiral that it was hard to believe that this was the same girl who was always suspicious and distrustful because of the way she was treated as a child. She saw that you should be happy about how far the Grand Marshal had come, but she couldn't get rid of the suspicions that were growing in her towards Antares, but for now she decided to leave them to herself...

„That's a good point, he should also know about this attack. Even if nothing comes of it, it's still better to inform him about everything.„ She said and everyone present agreed. For now, they had to deal with current matters anyway, mainly getting to Crypto Castle, and probably capturing it. She has enough troops to make it happen, but that's not a problem. The most important thing was to avoid bloodshed, but how could this be done when Shadow Weaver could be there, as well as Lady Cala, not to mention this young sorceress. As she thought of the Shadow Mistress, she looked over at Asindesa, who was staring ahead glumly. It was still hard for her to understand what kind of relationship the two women had. She knew that everyone deserved love, but you never thought that could include someone like her. She actually felt sorry for the Lady of Blades, because she seemed to be an honest person, full of honor and sacrifice, something like this shouldn't have happened to her. Besides, she seemed to know a lot about the state of the universe, and she needed another

source of information other than Catra's father and his subordinates. She also had to ask one thing, but I will do it together in Bow when they are alone.

„Maybe it's easiest if we get there stealthily, using Melog's cloaking like we did before.„ Adora said in a slightly cheerier voice, she seemed a bit less distressed than during the conversation with Halo

„It may be difficult, because this castle is a damn maze, but if we try, we will somehow manage to navigate its corridors. I think we still have the old datapads we used during the war, right?„ Catra looked at the others, stroking her shape-shifting companion with one hand and nervously tapping the table with the other.

„Sure! Entrapta gave them to us after our first meeting all those years ago. It was before the Ball, as you know.” Bow said and Catra grimaced.

„Yes, it was terrible, I hope the next prom you go to will be more fun.„ a voice grows coming from the shaded part of the tent. Frosta was there and didn't speak to anyone for most of the conversation, lost in dark thoughts. Catra smiled when she heard Frosta speak, and she seemed to be more cheerful. She was worried about the ice princess. She couldn't imagine that something like this could happen to someone. Although maybe she should…

„Well, I'll try to make the next ball much better!” Catra exclaimed and laughed.

„ Now I guess it's Scorpia's turn... She'll definitely be happy. This time we will all have our own pair, well almost all of us.„ Bow said and hesitated when he saw that both Knight and Frost looked down.

„ I'm sorry, I didn't mean to make you sad.„ said her husband in an apologetic tone.

„ It's nothing, we just met at the Archduke's ball... Prince Adamson. „ said Asindesa di Vir. Catra snorted, looking at the Lady of Blades with contempt, but she herself flinched at her words, as she remembered the Archduke and his cold blue eyes. However, she shook her head to clear the unpleasant image from her mind and decided to change the subject.

„Look, regardless of what happened, I think we should start negotiating. Lonnie is still in command, regardless of what Shadow Weaver may have done. She's not evil, she just made bad decisions and went too far. After all, her entire rebellion was not created to ensure her power, but to make life better for the inhabitants of our planet, in her opinion at least. I know it's hard to forgive her for what she did to all of us, but we must try to make peace, lest we plunge our planet into another war!„ she exclaimed, looking into everyone's eyes.

„First of all, you wrongly assume that she still has some power. Shadow Weaver never tolerated any rivals, and even if she didn't completely push her away, she could intimidate her and make her a puppet, just like I tried to do with Hordak. And there's a blonde-haired bitch... Lady Cala smells of arrogance. She was no different from Horde Prime, except perhaps that he had the power to justify his hubris. I don't believe she would let Lonnie stay in power.„ Catra said, Adora added.

„She is a lying manipulator who takes advantage of the kindness of others, but she is also a great fighter. If she wanted to take over the rebellion, she would. So we don't know who is in command in Crypto Castle now. Perhaps there is no one there to negotiate with.”

„But we have to try! We cannot miss the opportunity to end all this peacefully. I won't let another war break out just because I'm afraid to take the risk!„ she cried, clenching her fists.

„There is no more peace! Not after what Shadow Weaver and Lady Cala did! They killed your subjects!” Catra said in a sharp tone.

„ You know, Catra, your father's subordinates also killed several guards, your guards! You trained them yourself and I helped you with that!” Bow said in a serious tone.
„This is something completely different. They didn't do it on purpose, it was just an accident during a fight... Such things happen, everyone knows about it.„ said Catra, wagging her tail nervously, and Melog changed colors between blue and red and rubbed his head against his companion...

„The guards died because your father's servant had no regard for the lives of others. You heard yourself that it's just collateral damage for him!„ she exclaimed, feeling her anger rising.

„ Catra... I know that your father has become someone very close to you , and that you are very important to him. But he is not who you want him to be. He is... A mercenary commander... A man who has been waging war for decades. Things like this change people. They are not like us, like us!„ Bow said, trying to sound as calm as possible, and placed a hand on his wife's shoulder. Catra's hair ruffled and she said quietly, but her voice was full of anger.

„ Don't forget that we have all been involved in war all our lives. I was raised to be a soldier, just like Adora! That means we don't fit here either! Seen this way, no one on this planet fit here! You're right, war changes people. We all know it because it changed us all!”

Her husband sighed and then said.

„But here we either defended ourselves or fought because we were ordered to. His soldiers fight mainly because he pays them or for his and their glory. Except for Lady Ka's dogs, but they give the impression that they would love to rob us.”

Catra huffed in annoyance and said, pointing her finger at her husband's chest.

„They are looking for their homeland that was taken away from them. They are like Star Siblings, deprived of a home, forced to

fight for survival. But they came here, and they will help us fight the war that we abandoned because it was so convenient for us."

„What if one day he decides that Etheria will be the perfect homeland for his army? „ she said quietly, But hearing her words, the feline woman turned red with rage, just like her companion, although he also emanated other emotions.

„How dare you say such things! Since he arrived, he has given us no reason to distrust him! He helped defend your city, and now supports us in the fight against Shadow Weaver!„ She shouted at her, her voice full of anger. Perhaps she had made a mistake when she talked about her father in that way, but now she realized that, in fact, it MIGHT have happened at some point. If Catra weren't his daughter, then perhaps his arrival here wouldn't have been so peaceful after all. After all, he had already appointed himself Lord Protector of Taurus. Who knows what else he was planning.

„I don't want to take sides, I don't want them to be sides at all, but we should still be careful. Even if your father is a decent man…" Netossa said, but Catra interrupted her.

„Even!„ she exclaimed indignantly, but her wife put her hand on her shoulder, so the cat-like Woman fell silent for a moment.

„Even if your father is a decent man. Netossa continued. „We certainly can't say the same about his subordinates. You say that Lady Sorrowflame is not only a dragon, but also some kind of living dead! Until now, I thought that these types of creatures only live in fairy tales, the kind that scare children!" the general exclaimed , and cast a fleeting glance towards Frosty, who was curled up in her place.

„Lady Ka is equally terrible. Every time she looks at me, I feel like she sees me as an idiot who she would like to hurt. And when he looks at you, it seems like he hates you. Don't tell me you haven't noticed it yourself. – she said to Catra, who looked away, lost in thought... She may not have been able to look at her father objectively, but she wasn't blind. She saw that his subordinates

were bastards and murderers, without an ounce of honor. There was also one more issue that bothered her.

„Back then, when we were talking to Shadow Weaver, when you asked if she had done anything to your sister, she replied that we should look at Lady Ka's fingers... As you probably saw, she replaced one of her hands with a cybernetic prosthetic. But on her wedding day she was still normal. I don't know what happened to make her lose it, maybe she just wanted to replace it, apparently some people did that even with healthy body parts, but there's something I don't like about it.„ she said slowly, putting her suspicions into words. Catra frowned at her.

„What are you getting at?„ she said in a calmer voice, looking at her. She took a deep breath, because what she was about to say might be difficult for Catra…

„You mentioned that your sister's hand was mutilated. Her claws were removed... I wonder if the fact that Lady Ka lost her hand isn't because your father found out that she had somehow mutilated your sister and did the same to her.„ When she said these words, there was silence, and everyone gathered in the tent was silent, digesting the words they had just heard. Then Catra pursed her lips and extended her claws.

„Are you insinuating that my father would employ someone like that? And he wouldn't tell me anything! I'm sure if he found out that someone had hurt one of his daughters like that, he wouldn't let that person live! And certainly not walking free!„ she shouted in her face. She flinched, not so much because of her friend's tone, but rather because of what she said. Even her wife looked at her with amazement.

„This woman was created by the same man as you. She may have known her from her earliest days, almost from the moment she was born. She had many opportunities to hurt her. You can see that she is a nice person and would not hesitate to hurt your sister. We don't actually know what she did during the wedding, except this. that she was staying near the cemetery.„ She looked

at Frosta and Mermista. The Ice Princess hesitated before speaking.

„I thought Shadow Weaver wanted to cast a spell towards Entrapta, Now I'm not sure, I know it was a terrible mess.„ She looked at the others with apologetic eyes.

„You shouldn't involve her in this discussion!„ Catra said, bristling with anger again.

"Catra, I can speak for myself!" Frosta said

"But I'm not sure what happened there, or what she was doing there. I know there were so many of Lady Ka soldiers , some of whom died, and some of whom may have been killed by your sister." Mermista said in a serious tone and Catra turned to her and glared furiously.

„So you didn't see anything! You have no evidence! All you have are Shadow Weaver's words, and she always lies! „ said the Grand Marshal, and Adora added.

„Don't be offended, Glimmer, but you've always had a soft spot for her. You haven't seen who she really is." She didn't hurt you like she did us.

„Don't forget that she condemned my father to a fate worse than death and tortured me after I was kidnapped at the ball.„ She looked at her friends with sharp eyes.

„So maybe she wants to do what she did last time again, divide us so that we can't cooperate." Adora said , but Bow said thoughtfully.

„Maybe so, but we're not sure... It doesn't seem like she has anything to gain from such manipulation.

„ Maybe the easiest thing would be to question Lady Ka's men and herself.„ Mermista asked and they looked at each other.

„Maybe we'll do it anyway, because it's not a bad idea.„ She said and smiled, glad that she had postponed their argument for now. They were about to move on to their topics when Asindesa di Vir spoke up.

„I've gotten to know the Lord Admiral a little. He is a great commander, statesman and strategic genius. He won many victories against many opponents. I will never deny him the fact that billions of beings were saved thanks to him... But he is ruthless. There is no evidence that he committed war crimes, but it is very difficult to discern what his men are doing. He has many friends among politicians who are willing to hide his misdeeds. Besides , in the war he wages, everything is very... relative. The Swarm is not an enemy subject to the laws established by governments and priests. But I talked to him, and I can assure you that he is hiding a lot.„ The Lady of Blades' voice was strong and confident as she looked around everyone gathered as she spoke. Adora began to wonder, as did she. However, Catra, hearing her words, snorted and said.

„And we're supposed to believe you? How do I know you're not still working with Shadow Weaver, and don't want to turn us against each other, and I'm not just talking about those gathered here You want to slander my father so that we will break off our cooperation, so that your mistress can again harm our world! I'm not that naive!„ growled the Grand Marshal. The Hellknight looked at Catra very seriously, thought for a moment, and then said.

„I met your sister. I arrived on this planet the same day as your father, only unofficially. I met her, quite by accident, in Brightmoon... I wanted to go on a picnic with her, a unformal date... I've never been on one... And so has she, if I understand correctly what she told me about her hometown and her later life.”

„Get to the point or stay silent and spare us these sob stories.„ Catra interrupted her, clenching and unclenching her hands. Melog shone in many colors, clearly trying to convey the emotions

swirling in his companion's heart. The Lady of Blades nodded and continued.

„We ran into them when they were shopping for new outfits. They wanted to go to your wedding. To be honest, it was only a short moment, but I didn't think they were afraid of Shadow Weaver.„ She explained in a calm voice, regardless of the feline woman's accusations.

„You know, kitty, there might be something to it. Shadow Weaver said that they had only recently met this Eti. Do you remember how I told you about meeting your sister? She was weird but nice. Just like the other kids. That deaf girl who... and that green-haired elf... But they all came from Kesler, the same planet as you. „ the heroine of the Galaxy looked at the Saihe soldier, who had been watching them impassively until now. However, when Adora told about the Green-Haired Saiha she had met, his eyes widened as if he was shocked, but he replied in a calm voice.

„Yes. I am from Kesler, as are many of the Lord Admiral's soldiers. We serve him to avenge our lost world. Many were simply soldiers who served in the armies of our world. We often had nothing to do with ourselves. Believe me, no one wants to live in a refugee camp, especially in Atrax. However, I would like to ask, What was the name of this elf... Saihe, as you call us here?„ he looked straight into Adora's eyes, who thought for a moment before answering.

„Her name was Itel. She was covered in strange tattoos, many of them looked like burning roses, but I couldn't recognize the others, although I think some of them were similar to the ones that... Captain Moonshadow had.”

„I also met her, she was with me when... my palace was broken into. She yelled at that deaf girl.” She looked at the soldier, who seemed absolutely shocked.

„This girl…. This Itel... She is my daughter. I only recently found out that she is alive, but you confirmed it... I am grateful to you.

There was also a red-haired girl with her. She is my friend's sister. He also thought that he was losing her along with the whole family...„ This time it was clear that he was shaken. Even though he seemed like a tough veteran, she now saw tears in his eyes.

„I met her too, during the wedding.„ Frosta suddenly called and went to the middle of the tent, and a smile appeared on her pale face. „ Earlier, Adora asked me and Swiftwind, who also met her earlier, to look for them and... stop them. I think we had a bit of a fight with This girl and almost a duel, but then... You know what happened...„ She said and looked down.

„Gee, I like her already. Then I remember the good times. Duels for honor, or just plain bullshit. Maybe you'll finish it when everything passes.” General Netossa laughed. Frosta responded with an equally kind smile.

„Okay, so this girl is your daughter and the other girl's friend, and they both hang out with Catra's sister. So you could say you're personally interested in finding her, right? „ she asked and looked at Izai, who after a moment of hesitation nodded and said.

„Yes, she's all I have left. My two co-wives and husband survived, but we are no longer together. All these experiences made us unable to be together. These terrible memories came back whenever we were together. I guess they now live on Castroval, a planet that is home to many of our people... „ he thought for a moment and added...„ I was listening to your conversation, but I decided not to interfere in the whole conversation, because I prefer not to make enemies of people in higher positions,

„You've already made an enemy of me by spreading slander about my friend.„ said Catra, staring at the mercenary with fury in her eyes. However, he answered her calmly.

„I am a simple soldier who means little compared to the great people of this world... Even people like you, because, if you're sorry, you're not the most dangerous people I know, and certainly not the most terrible. I guess you would like to ask me about the

Lord Admiral now, so that I can dispel your doubts about his... actions.„ He looked at them, arms crossed on his chest. „Just a moment ago, I would have liked to keep quiet about everything, because I really don't want to make enemies. I am a reasonable person. After what I experienced on Kesler, I don't want to risk my life unnecessarily. However, you told me that you could bring me back together with my daughter. That's why I decided to be honest with you... I know it's a lot of risk... „ he looked significantly at Catra, who gave him a distrustful look. „ So if you swear that I will be with my daughter again, then something. You'll find out from me.”

She nodded.

„None of Catra's sister's friends will get hurt. We wouldn't hurt them even if they weren't her friends, because that's not how we act here. You have my word for this, and probably the word of everyone gathered here.„ She looked at the others, and everyone nodded, even Catra, though she still looked at the man with dislike. Saihe So he took a deep breath and said.

„There is no doubt that the Lord Admiral is a great commander, and that he saved Atrax, where he was recognized as a national hero. There is no doubt about it. However, he achieved his greatest victory by sacrificing the lives of tens of thousands of civilians... „ he said, and there was silence for a moment.

„Explain.„ she said briefly, feeling fear rising in her heart. Until now, she had thought that the Lord Admiral was not the man he wanted to appear to be. However, when her fears were confirmed, she felt her heart go cold. Now she greatly regretted that she had not been wrong.

„It was the time when the evacuation from the planet was being prepared. Of course, not all citizens could be saved, there was a limited number of places on the ships, but they could still fit tens, maybe hundreds of thousands of people... The ships were supposed to leave Kesler in two groups to make it easier to avoid capture by the Swarm. Few were aware that the two groups were

not equal. One included politicians, businessmen, members of influential families, as well as specialists in important fields. The second, much larger one, contained ordinary inhabitants of the planet. The two groups flew separately, but the latter headed straight for the Swarm forces. They were bait, and the ships scattered, fleeing from the enemy, who also scattered, allowing the Fearless Armada to easily surround and eliminate individual enemy ships with virtually no losses, but all the civilians in the second group were killed. Of course, many managed to evacuate before the entire planet was cut off by the fleet, but still a fraction of the total population... I was lucky, due to military experience. Thousands were sacrificed in the name of Victory, perhaps it was strategically wise , but in my opinion it makes us not much better than the Swarm... „ he finished bitterly. This time the silence lasted longer and was much deeper. Now she felt like she was falling into a abys. She was terrified. They invited the monster to their place. Someone who was willing to sacrifice everything to win. She had witnessed this recently when he defended what Lady Sorrowflame had done, when he talked about collateral damage. It all made a coherent whole. They had barely dealt with one tyrant, fought against his heirs, and welcomed another, perhaps even more dangerous one. Now their problem with Shadow Weaver seemed so insignificant. She felt her husband's hand on her shoulder and looked up. He looked at her tenderly, as if to say that everything would be fine, and even though she knew it wouldn't be, it still warmed her heart. But then they both looked at Catra. The Grand Marshal stared at Corporal Izai with wide eyes. Her face was expressionless, only her hands were clenching, and even Melog was almost colorless. She finally spoke quietly, her voice almost dead.

„Do you have any evidence to support your words?”

Saihe shook his head and then said.

„I don't have them with me, it would be too risky.. But I can take the queen to meet my companions who will confirm my words. Even other evidence of much more serious crimes!”

„More serious crimes? „ She asked in disbelief.„ What crimes can be more serious than leading to the death of tens of thousands of people?

Saihe looked her straight in the eyes, and said softly and firmly, All his words were like hammer blows.

„Dropping nuclear warheads on your own capital after being exiled.”

She felt nauseous and the blood drained from her face and hands. Netossa poured herself something stronger, Memista uttered a string of curses as strange as they were ugly. Frosta looked at everyone with questioning eyes, lost and Forgotten. Bow put on a hard face, determined to defend her. Her, their child, all their loved ones. She might not need protection, but it was good to have someone so brave by her side, especially in times like these. Adora tried to hug her wife, but she pushed her away, then walked up to the soldier, put her claw to his forehead, and muttered.

„Since you can't prove anything, I assume you're making false accusations against your commander. This is definitely a misdemeanor according to the rules of the Fearless Armada, so you are arrested, and then you will be court-martialed, do you understand?”

The soldier only smiled in response, so the feline woman pressed a claw against his forehead, causing blood to drip down his face.

„Understood!„ She screamed at him.

„Catra! Enough!„ she called in a commanding tone, but her friend Ani didn't move, she just stared at Izai with her heterochromic eyes, until finally her wife wrapped her arms around her waist and moved her away from the soldier. Then she hugged her tightly and tenderly.

„It's okay, darlingI'm with you, I understand that it's hard for you, but we'll get through this together.„ she said in a quiet, reassuring

voice. Melog stood between her and Izai.

„Am I under arrest?„ Saihe asked, looking at her seriously.

"No, you're not.„ she said seriously to the man, but then Catra broke free from her wife's embrace and said.

„Of course it is! You can't say things like that, you can't tarnish someone's name!„ She was breathing heavily with rage.

„Catra, we can't arrest someone just for words. Even if they were lies, we still cannot forbid them from being told. „ Adora said, extending her hand to her.

„Maybe just wait until he shows you the evidence about who the Lord Admiral is. I know you're very happy to have found your family, but please…" Bow said, but the feline woman turned to him abruptly and Screamed.

„You can't even imagine it! You always had a big and happy family, almost like a fairy tale!„ She turned to her and said, her voice breaking, as if she was trying not to cry.

„You did it on purpose! Because you can't stand the fact that your mother is a murderer, that she is a pirate! That she tried to burn down the entire city to take Adora's sword! That's why you don't want me to have a real family! You just want to take everything away from me out of jealousy!„ she looked at her with her multi-colored eyes. It hurt. Any mention of her mother, especially who she had become, always made her heart bleed. It was mean, if not for a worse word.

„Please leave before you say anything else. Before you say something that can't be undone. „ she said in a cool tone to the cat-like woman, who nodded and said.

„Fine, it will be as you wish!„ and she went outside.

„I'll try to talk to her. It may not be easy, but I need to calm down a little. I know what she's going through now.„ Adora said and

followed her wife. Now she looked for the others. Everyone looked at her surprised. Until now, she had managed to hide the truth about her mother, that she had become Captain Moonshadow. She asked Scorpia and Perfuma not to tell anyone what they found out at that dinner, and she had to rely on the former strike captain to keep her mouth shut , but she always had trouble keeping secrets.

„Is the queen alive? But how?„ Netossa asked in disbelief.

„Your mother is alive! That's great! I missed her!„ Frosta exclaimed, beaming with joy. Now she was absolutely happy. Mermista, however, looked at her distrustfully .

„Why haven't you told anyone about this yet? This concerns us all! „ said the sea princess seriously. She took a deep breath and she began to talk about what she had learned. About her mother becoming a pirate after she was imprisoned . She also had to tell about the fact that she tried to kill Adore for Icarus. She jumped out, everyone was silent and looked at her with sympathy, but also disbelief.

„How is something like this possible! We have known each other for so many years!! She was at our wedding. Even though she experienced so many tragedies, she was always full of love for you and for everyone. How was it possible that she became such a person?„ Netossa said in disbelief, and Mermisa added.

„You told your father about this?”

She shook her head and replied.

„No, not yet. To tell you the truth, I didn't know how to tell him about it, especially since I didn't know how the situation would end.

„But he should know that! Certainly earlier than me!„ said the sea princess seriously. She sighed and said, looking down.

„Yes, you're probably right. I should tell you first. When he gets back to Brightmoon, I'll tell you all about it. „ She sighed and they started discussing smaller, current matters. Finally, when everything was arranged, she turned to her friends and advisors for one more matter.

„What do we do about the Halo request?„ she looked at the others. Netossa sighed and said.

„It's Adora's decision anyway... We have no say in this matter. We'll have to wait until she comes back and hope she can calm Catra down.”

„ You're right. „ she nodded, although she was full of bad forebodings. Then, as everyone began to disperse, overwhelmed by the dark things they were talking about. when they were about to be alone, she turned to the knight of hell.

„I would like you to stay for a while, because I need to talk to you.”

The Lady of Blades looked at her in surprise, but she nodded and did as she asked. The three of them stayed in the command tent, she even told the guards to leave.

„I had an accident some time ago... „ she began cautiously, not sure how to talk about such matters.

„You mean losing your power? Well, I don't know much about your…„ the Knight began, but she shook her head and cut her off.

„That's not the point. We almost didn't tell anyone about it, but there was an accident when Shadow Weaver was escaping from prison. Some man... You explain it better, darling.„ she looked at her husband, who narrowed his eyes in thought and said.

„A man injected something into Glimmer... We're not sure what it was, it's definitely not any poison, but how it infected her body. I don't know who this man was, but as I chased him while

escaping, he turned into a bat and then burned up in the rays of the bright moons.

She felt cold again when she saw the worry on Asindesa's face.

„It was a vampire, although I'm not sure what kind. He probably injected you with some of his blood, but your body seemed to fight it off, for the most part, maybe because of who your mother was. However, your child will be a Dhampir, a hybrid of human and vampire...„ The lady of the blades said carefully.

„What does this mean? „ she asked fearfully. She understood that there would be other opportunities, but she got used to the thought of it, she would soon become a mother... She would have to wait.

„I can guess what you're thinking about now. Whether or not you give birth is up to you, no one else cares, but being a Dhampir is not horrible at all. I have only met one or two of this kind, for they were never numerous, but in ancient Ustalaw many aristocrats were Dhampirs, some became great heroes. Its life will probably be different than the life of his peers, especially here, he will be happy like everyone else. I hope this reassures you.„ The Knight explained. Indeed, she felt a relief that was hard to describe. Then she asked, at least one more time.

„What about Frosta? Is there anyone who can help her?”

This time Asindesa became gloomy

„This is a more complicated matter. To be honest, I don't know much about the undead. Strigas... I haven't heard anything from them. I don't know how I could help your friend... In the pact worlds, there is a planet called Eox. It is dead, not in the way that atmosphereless moons are, but it literally emanates the energy of death. Mainly the undead live there, although for some time now they have also been letting the living in. Maybe if she went there, someone would help her, or at least she would be among others like her. On the other hand, I'm not sure she would be happy

there. It's hard to imagine a place more different than Etheria. „ Said the Knight

„ I see. „ she said quietly, crying to herself over the fate of her friend.

Chapter End Notes

.It was hard to finish this chapter. Feel free to comment!

Painful separations – part one

Chapter Summary

> New chapter. I know Glimmer is the most powerful warlock on Etheria, but not in terms of experience. Please comment.

She ran, feeling tears streaming down her face. Her companion ran right behind her. Shogi now took the form of a Giant Spider, she had no idea why he did it, but she didn't want to think about something like that now. She felt as if her heart had died. Perhaps it was already dead, if she believed what she overheard under the queen's tent. When Glimmer ordered them to leave, she guessed that she might want to talk about her, so she decided to hide and eavesdrop. Deep down, she knew she wouldn't hear anything good, but she had to find out. She had to know the truth. However, she didn't expect that she would learn anything like this She didn't want to leave Etheria for anything in the world, and she certainly didn't want to go to a place like Eox, where only living dead lived. She wasn't like them! She Lived! She wasn't some Strigoi or some other Ghoul. She wasn't dead. They couldn't be right, she was alive! She stopped for a moment and put her fingers to her neck to feel for the Pulse. She wasn't sure if she felt something, but she thought she did... So maybe it wasn't so bad. Not at all! She calmed down. She thought for a moment, and then decided to look around the camp and look for something. People in the camp were preparing for the coming storm. They hid their belongings in tents and covered the rest of what they couldn't hide with sheets and tied them to the ground with ropes. The fires were extinguished and the gates were closed. She looked for a group that looked relatively well-groomed. At first she couldn't find anyone suitable until she finally saw Star Siblings. She knew them from previous visits to Etheria . they were friends with Catra and Adora and the rest. She remembered that they were freedom

fighters and helped liberate their planet. But now they wore the military uniforms of the Lord Admiral's soldiers. She hesitated as she remembered everything she had recently heard about Catra's Father, how evil he was. But they were friends after all. They couldn't have changed that much, could they? So she took a deep breath, and she and Shogi walked over to them.

„Hello, it's me Frosta!„ she exclaimed, trying to sound cheerful. All three turned to her, surprised. A woman with cybernetic hands, she think her name was Tallstar, turned to her and said.

„Oh hello princess! How can we serve you?!„ She looked confused. Many people from other planets looked like that when talking to them. She didn't understand why they were behaving like this, after all, she was a normal girl, at least she used to be. She hesitated, and then the other woman, Talstar's younger sister , whose name was Starla, rolled her eyes and turned to her older sister.

„Come on, stop it, sister! You're talking to her like you're talking to a customs officer! She's Adora and Catra's friend! Invite her to our tent!„ the younger girl scolded the older one, and then turned to her.

„Come to us with your companion.„ she pointed at Shogi . From the moment he revealed his true form, everyone was giving her friend scared looks, but Starlla didn't seem to care, probably because she was very brave and hardened from the fight. „We'll treat you to hot chocolate with Rum. We have a lot of rum here!”

Or she just wasn't afraid of Shogi because she was tipsy.

„I'd like to try it, but maybe without rum, because I'm I don’t like alcohol.„ She said carefully so as not to offend anyone. She once heard that Glimmer got drunk for the first time when she was sixteen. She reached for a bottle of cider hidden by one of the servants. Apparently she was so dizzy that she couldn't get to her room. She teleported around the castle until she landed in the moat. Netossa liked to tell this story every chance she got,

embarrassing the queen. She entered the tent, where a red-haired boy was stirring something in a small pot. To her surprise, she liked the scent, so she felt very relieved. She thought that maybe But the symptoms were going away, that she was somehow getting better.

„Hello, darling!„ said Starla, throwing herself at the redhead's neck, who blushed. At this time, Tallstar was trying to communicate with her brother via communicator, the storm was coming and it was making it difficult.

„Damn, Jewelstar could stop sulking, I know it might be difficult for him, but maybe everything will work out, and after all, even if it turns out differently, he still has to live somehow.„ growled the female cybernetic Clovers.

„You know, sister, it would be easy to say because your girlfriend is... you know, And my Kay is here with me.„ she hugged her boyfriend and then continued.„ And his heart situation is terribly complicated, like something out of a romantic novel!

Tallstar rolled her eyes.

"Me and Dilayla are not a couple... I mean... It's complicated...„ She explained irritably.

„It's almost like a status on a Book of Faces!„ said a red-haired boy who was called Kay. Feeling a bit confused by this family's exchange, and also remembering why she actually came here, she said.

„Do you have a mirror or something here that I could look at„ she asked, and Starla went to her locker and said.

Oh, I'm sorry! I think I forgot about you a bit, but we're worried about our big brother. – she apologized and started throwing things. Then Kay looked at her, and he must have recognized her from his recent conversation with Halo, because he started looking at her warily, so she pulled her hood up. She realized that now everyone must know who she really was, it wasn't a pleasant

thought. She did n't want everyone to see her as a monster. Finally, Starla handed her a small mirror, the kind you sometimes took with you on a camping trip to wash yourself, or something like that. She saw her reflection, and at first glance she looked normal, just a little paler than usual, but Everything seemed fine! She was almost happy that she was fine now and Halo words were just a bad lie. She smiled to herself, and then she saw her teeth, which at first looked almost normal, but then her teeth came out, and she saw that there was a essentially two rows of sharp fangs. She let out a short scream, and then her face changed again, her features became sharper and her ears became pointed.

„Has something happened?„ Starla asked, then She looked at her and inhaled with a whoosh.

„To much… "she shouted and hid her face in her hands. Bloody tears ran down her face. She wasn't ashamed of crying, but something like this was... But she couldn't stop. She knew that everyone was looking at her, and the young soldier held his hand close to the gun. The others seemed a little less scared, but she guessed that creatures like her… What she had become were more common outside the Fallen Empire.

„Is there anything we can do for you?„ Tallstar asked , with concern but also anxiety in her eyes.

„Nobody can do anything for me. „ she said quietly in a saddened voice, but then she thought better of it. Was there really nothing anyone could do for her? Maybe Mikah, he was one the most powerful sorcerers on Etheria, or Aunt Casta , she was the Head Sorceress. She had the help of all of Mystacor, all its sorcerers and all the knowledge they had there. Maybe they'll work something out. She was of course Lady Sorroowflame, she was not-dead, just like her. She probably knew more about these things than anyone on all of Etheria ... But she didn't want to have anything to do with her. She was evil, wicked ! As did the Lord Admiral and all those who served him. Who else does she have left? She thought about it and understood. Mikah wasn't the most powerful

sorcerer on Etheria, Shadow Weaver was. She was an evil woman who hurt everyone so much, but… Catra's sister was with her. And Nightgale ... She was the daughter of the Shadow Mistress, so maybe she could convince her mother to help her. Who else could help her than the one who cast the spell that made her suffer so much? She believed that Nightgale was not as bad as others saw her. She actually has a conscience, unlike Catra's father... And Halo. Until now, she had viewed Star Sister as a kind of step-aunt. But she was connected to the one who cursed her, this Charon. How could she do this to her! That's why she didn't want her friends to agree to her terms. She was a liar, and a traitor. She couldn't let give her Darla! Perhaps if she does something herself, they won't lose this wonderful ship.

„Tell Catra if she's looking that I went to see her sister.„ she said and determinedly went with Shogi into the night, not against the gusty wind and thunder coming from the sky.

„Okay, guys, let's pack!.„ exclaimed Bina, who was supervising the packing of the monument onto the ship. Captain Moonshadow smiled to herself under her mask. That woman was a good mother, even though she never wanted to be one. The same couldn't be said about her, at least that's what she thought... She robbed her own daughter, and before that she tried to murder her friend, and what's more, she brought here a woman who was her enemy, even though she didn't remember all her crimes. So she couldn't be called an ideal mother, period. But not only for this reason. She was also starting to feel guilty about Tirin. The girl was with her from the very beginning of her pirate career. She didn't pass on anyone more loyal, anyone who was willing to give up more for another person. However, she felt like she was taking advantage of this girl. Tirin betrayed her people, almost her species, for her, and murdered dozens of people to free her. She knew she was complicit in what she had to do, and worse yet, she took her with her, exposing her to a similar incident in the future. But she was starting to realize that she couldn't turn this girl into a pirate, no one her age should experience what she had, and she

deserved a normal life. She looked at the Azlantean who was talking to Rosie, very excited. Perhaps he will find a place for her here. She guessed that Bina wanted this for her children too, she had seen it for some time as she looked around the castle and watched them try to fraternize with the rebel members. She should also think about a better future for the crippled girl forever trapped in the biosuit. In fact, it would be easier for her because of her place in the society of this planet. Damm! She was a queen! She had no idea whether she still wanted to be a and, more importantly, whether she should be, but she still hoped that it would somehow help guarantee a safe future for Tirin. Of course, she just had to figure out how... How to get back to her family... It was difficult. She didn't actually remember they. She knew she had a daughter and a husband, and that she loved them both very much, but she didn't remember much else. Just fragments of memories, usually happy, but sometimes also sad. Slowly she remembered more and more. However, she couldn't let it all go on for so long. She had to hurry.

First of all, she remembered the words of this elven sorceress and that she had to help prevent a catastrophe. Unlike most members of the rebellion, she understood well what threat the Swarm posed. Although she had never faced this opponent, she knew how dangerous it was. It was feared throughout the galaxy more than even the Star Empire, and she couldn't imagine what she would do if she lost her newly reclaimed homeland to unsatiated hunger. Worse yet, the seemingly mindless Fleet was actually controlled by an adversary older than all known civilizations. The name „ The Firsts ones” was probably familiar to her from her old life, it was associated with glory and sadness, but she couldn't remember anything specific now. And now she was just a pirate who could only Destroy and pillage... What could she do to oppose Such power?

And that wasn't the end of the worries. A much more tangible opponent was the Lord Admiral. From what she had heard about him, he was a dangerous man, a tyrant hungry for power. She will also have to oppose him somehow, and also protect her daughter from him, because she had no doubt that at the first opportunity

she would want to get rid of Queen Etheria, the real one, because she deserved this title. She could only count that her daughter has already learned the true nature of Antares, and will not be fooled by his smooth words. Fortunately, they had support here, the one who had already overthrown him once. She just had to hope that the black tom hadn't lost his claws.

There was one more problem she was afraid to even think about. Her husband was alive, the man she loved more than life was alive! She remembered how she grieved after his death, even though she didn't know the circumstances, so now when she discovered that he was alive, she felt her love flare up in her heart again. The problem was that there was her second husband. Reh-zar gave her support when she was at the bottom. He gave her love at a time when all she felt was pain and hatred. During these five years, he was her support, a best friend, someone she could always count on in the brutal life of a pirate. They both understood each other very well and were a great couple. Damn, they made love a lot... Did that mean she was Cheating on her real houseband... But then which one was real? She loved both of them, but each of them loved someone else, a different her. She wasn't sure which one was the real one either. She slowly stopped being Captain Moonshadow as her memories returned, but she had no idea who she was becoming... She wasn't sure who she should be either... And the time to think was quickly running out, because Reh-zar would soon arrive with a new ship.

She sighed and decided to focus on the next task. She looked around and looked for the elven Sorceress who was standing in the square and was raising one hand and stretching her other arm upwards. She was the one who was supposed to take her to her husband... to Mikah. She wasn't sure if she should trust her, after all she was... Well she was a very easygoing woman, but they didn't have any other misticso she had to trust her.

„I just need to give the instructions to my crew, and then you will do what you have to do.„ She turned to the Sorceress, who continued to stand on one leg.

„I'm not in a hurry!„ Ireanis exclaimed happily, her tone as cheerful as ever. She frowned and asked the sorceress.

„What are you doing exactly?”

„ I practice yoga, or at least I think so, I've only seen others do it a few times, but apparently it's great for health and other things. You know, I'm still thirsty, so I hope this helps a little. „ She replied, spreading her arms to the sides.

„ And that helps?„ she looked carefully at her sorceress.

„It's hard to say. I still feel thirsty ,but now my back hurts! „ The silver”haired woman replied, smiling broadly. Well, you could only hope that when they teleported, she would still have everything in place.

She searched for her crew, and found second mate Gydwa, boatswain Kaert, and chief engineer Gozamund .

„Do you remember the instructions?” she asked sharply, and Nuar nodded.

„We'll do as you say, ma'am.„ he said

„ Indeed, we will do as you instructed„ Veska replied, staring won with your one eye. She knew that she couldn't trust her completely, but fortunately she had gained so much support among the crew that for some time the second mate would also have to be obedient. But she was still worried about whether she would risk it and betray...

„Actually, the Captain is the queen now or something, right? So I'm thinking that when this is all over, we probably deserve some knighthood or something. „ Petty Officer Keart said , grinning.

„ Why not? This is an interesting idea.„ She said it quite honestly. Her crew deserved knighthoods, and much more, for all they had

done for her. Well, at least most of them. Now she realized that someone was missing.

„And where is Tonado? „ she asked, looking around for her first mate.

„I'm here!„ Skiittermander shouted happily from behind her. She turned around and saw Tonada , who was packed for a long hike. She raised an eyebrow and asked her first mate.

„Where are you going?”

„With you Captain!„ Skittermander answered her, clearly surprised by this question. „You need the protection of your most loyal Servant! It will be a difficult expedition, into definitely hostile territory, full of enemies and ambushes.”

She sighed heavily. Tonado was always absolutely loyal to her and she could always count on him. She wanted him to stay here and make sure Gydwa didn't do anything stupid. On the other hand, she knew that if a rebellion broke out in her absence, despite all his bravery, she would most likely fall. So she smiled at him under her mask and said.

„Well, my dear, you can come with me! „ she said and gave further instructions to her subordinates, hoping that they would follow them to the letter, although, as she knew, life would get complicated. Then she moved with her first mate to the Elf, but before she reached her she saw that Tirin was standing in her way.

„Captain, I... I'd like to go with you too! „ said the girl, trying to sound as confident as possible. She sighed heavily again, looking at the girl. Since she decided that in the event of a mutiny aboard the Tonado would be safer with her, she should also have taken her navigator with her. It also had practical significance. She was the only one who had any experience navigating space, so without her it would be harder for the rest of them to do something really stupid. Of course, due to her health, adventures

were much riskier for her than for anyone else. On other hand, the girl wasn't as defenseless as it might seem. After all, without her their rebellion would not have succeeded, and on top of that, she was the one who enabled them to rob that museum during her daughter's wedding.

„Okay, although I hope that Ireanis will be able to transport us all, but she is a talented sorceress... Maybe just a bit specific...„ she said carefully and together they went to Ireanis, who was sitting on the ground this time, with her legs behind her neck.

„Look what I did! Now we just have to hope I can get out of this! But it shouldn't be difficult!„ she exclaimed and tried to get up on her feet, but she fell down. Looking at this, Tirin hesitated, but after a while she pulled herself together and walked with Skittermander to the Elf and together in the table close to each other.

„It may be difficult but... I'm almost sure that we will bring all the body parts together, sixty percent yes!„ Ireanis called. She sighed and said.

„You know what? Maybe it's better if I take care of it? Just take my hand and think about where we need to be, okay?”She asked the sorceress carefully, but she waved her hand and said.

„Okay, in a way it's been centuries since I last did this! „She said, and then the four of them embraced and spread their wings, used their power, and disappeared in a flash of light.

Getting to the landing pad wasn't that difficult, especially since most of the guards hid in the guardhouses to hide from the storm that had just arrived. Snow began to fall, lightning appeared in the sky and a gusty wind blew. She felt cold, but not as cold as she should have been. she knew it was part of her curse too. Although she didn't fully remember those moments when she was overcome by an unstoppable hunger, she remembered perfectly

that she didn't feel cold like normal beings. After all, dead people don't feel the cold, that's what all the old stories told her as a child said. Now she has become such a person.

However, finding a suitable ship was much more difficult. The biggest problem was the fact that she wasn't good at piloting flying vehicles. She was able to drive small Antek gravity vehicles, but larger things, including those floating in the air, were a mystery to her. For a moment she felt powerless again, completely helpless. What was she supposed to do to get to the castle and meet Nightgale? She had to fly away from here somehow, and she couldn't cope with the first challenge! She was indeed a clumsy and stupid Frosta. She sat down on the ground and started sniffing. It's terribly stupid that you're talking, she had bullets in her nose, but she was crying blood. Suddenly, she heard footsteps behind her, so she turned around, summoning two ice hammers, but to her surprise, she saw Sea Hawk, wearing a blue leather jacket, standing in front of her, holding his hip.

„Are you looking for a captain to go on a great adventure with him!” he called, and she blinked twice before answering.

„Actually, I'm looking for a pilot, and I don't really think about adventures. I just want to find a certain friend and ask her to help me.”

„Oh mission in the name of friendship and Brotherhood! Or rather Sisterhood ! Fortunately, you found me! Sea Hawk ! Best pilot on Etheri! „ The Captain called, but she heard voices coming from the darkness and she heard them .

„ You better not exaggerate! You're as much of a pilot as I am a harpy! As soon as you get up in the air, you turn green and return your last meal!„ and from shadows came Mermista , after her came Netossa.

„What are you doing here?„ She asked, honestly surprised. Then Netossa began to explain

„It's not that we wanted to eavesdrop on what Glimmer and Asindesa were talking about , but we actually eavesdropped... That's how it happened. I Then we saw you running somewhere, so we decided to follow you. I must admit that we lost track quite quickly... „ the general scratched her temple. Then Mermista interjected.

„It was quite hard to find you, but we saw you leaving the Star Siblings' tent, so we came up with the idea of asking them where you were going instead of wandering all over the camp again. Well, we figured you'd be here.„ said the Sea Princess.

„And you're here to stop me.„ She stated without anger, but Shogii covered her and started barking at both women and the man, although he had the form of a snake with many legs. He liked changing shapes more and more.

„Actually, no! To be honest, we would like to go with you, or rather I would like to and Mermista's husband...„ Netossa looked sideways at Sea Hawk , who responded indignantly.

„But I'm Sea Hawk, the most famous sailor on the planet! My wife asked me to keep you safe!”

They both looked at him doubtfully and his wife explained.

„Honestly, I sent you on this mission because you are afraid of his mother, who is visiting us tomorrow... I don't understand why you are afraid of this woman! She is the nicest mother-in-law you can imagine. It's not my fault that she always makes you feel like you've failed her expectations.„ Mermista looked behind her husband and shook her head, but he looked at her with resentful eyes and said.

„You don't know what it's like when your mother laughs at the name you chose. She always tells me that a Sea Hawk is actually a seagull, and a seagull is actually a sea vulture. I became the captain of the ship precisely to do something that she can't do better, because she's even more afraid of the water than Catra.”

His wife patted him on the shoulder and said.

„Everyone knows that you are the greatest sea captain in the entire galaxy!”

„But you don't even know why and where I want to go.„ she said uncertainly, worried about how both women would react to her plan. She wasn't sure if it made any sense at all. Netossa looked up, raising one eyebrow.

„I guess it has to do with that sorceress, am I right?„ she said, smiling slightly. She looked down and said

„I wanted her to help me convince her mother to somehow reverse the spell. However, we are friends. I don't know what happened to her then, but she probably didn't have full control over it. I know how you see her. That she is the daughter of two of the most evil people on the planet. But now we found out that Catra's father is also a terrible person, but his daughter is wonderful! She can be like that too, if you just give her a chance. I know it sounds naive and stupid, but I can try!„ she looked at both women, feeling that she must sound terribly idiotic to them, but Netossa slowly nodded and said

„Well, I suspected something like that. I'm not sure if your plan will work, but I think it's worth a try. That's why I'll go with you. Silverwing is here and I will be able to take you wherever necessary . Besides, it's not just about you. For now, Glimmer must figure out how to react to what she has learned about Catra's father. In addition, he has problems with regaining his power and... the other thing. Catra, on the other hand, has to deal with the truth about herself and her family. Neither of them is in the position to negotiate peace terms right now. I hope we can work something out. I won't deny that looking at the disfigured face of this magical bitch will be difficult for me to bear, but somehow I will manage. This will be a risky mission, if what they said about this blonde is true, we saw what she really is. But the three of us...„ she looked at Shogi . “The four of us can handle it.”

„I asked Sea Hawk to fly with you. It's not just about his problems with his mother, but you'll need someone else to watch your back, and I can't do that, because there has to be someone reasonably reasonable and objective here, otherwise everything will fall apart again, as it happened before. was.„ Mermista said and smiled , and her husband knelt down on one knee and said.

„My ladies, it will be an honor for me to be able to protect you from... „ He didn't finish because Netossa laughed and said.

„We can defend ourselves, but your help won't hurt.”

The five of them then hugged, and then she made her way to Netossa's vehicle at the landing pad.

Painful Separations - Part Two

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It all had to be lies. There was simply no other option. It couldn't be true. Otherwise... She couldn't imagine an Alternative. She had heard many lies in her life, so she was certain that she would be able to recognize if her father wanted to deceive her. At first, she didn't trust him. He was a foreign military commander from outside the Empire, who could pose a threat to all of them. He reminded her too much of those who wanted to destroy her life, and the lives of all the inhabitants of Etheria. But she had given him a chance, at first at Glimmer's request, but she also wanted to get to know him, to get to know herself. And then he told her his story... And her story. He had confirmed everything she had once suspected. He had proven that he was more than everyone thought. He had shown that Shadow Weaver had always been wrong about her! He had told her that she was created for something more, he had made her scion! She was to inherit his entire legacy after his death. For the first time in her life, she felt... important. This was what she wanted when she tried to conquer Etheria, when she almost took over the Horde. To be someone no one wanted to see in her! She had her friends and her beloved, but then she felt that her life was complete. Her father respected her and admired her achievements. In his fate she saw a reflection of her life, everything she's been through. She felt as if all her suffering, everything she had experienced had prepared her for this meeting! This was to be her legacy, her destiny. No one but Adora could understand it. They all had families, pasts, and a sense of belonging. The place she grew up in was hell, she was always afraid that she would never fully adapt to the place she lived in now, that she would always remain a bit of a stranger. And now she had her homeland, her past, she finally understood Who she was. And now she was going to lose it

because some soldier told some scary stories! He had to be lying, there was no doubt about it. Was he in the service of Shadow Weaver? They already knew that she had many supporters, not only in the People's Rebellion, but also among people connected to her patron, to that being she saw in the book... With Nyarlathotep... Of course, she didn't believe that he was this whole Outer God, but he certainly had great power and influence! Could this soldier be his servant, like this psychopathic aristocrat? Maybe this Knight, this lover of Shadow Weaver was also in cahoots with him? That would explain why they both worked together to slander her father. Was this all one big conspiracy? That would explain everything! They were all simply enemies who had conspired against her and her family. They wanted to take away everything she loved! She couldn't believe them! Because if did that, then... She didn't want to think about it. She had to show everyone as soon as possible where the truth lay! What great lies were told there!

At first she wanted to run to Lady Ka right away and tell her everything, order her to arrest that soldier and the Hell Knight for treason… But she didn’t do that, although she didn’t really know why… So she went to a place where she could think everything over, where she could get rid of the doubts that were rattling in the back of her head. Above the camp was a mountain peak, not very high, but very steep, that most people couldn't climb without climbing gear, but she was agile enough to get there without too much difficulty. She knew it was unwise, because a storm was about to break out and lightning would strike so high, and the cold wind that whipped her cheeks like sharp icy needles could push her hundreds of meters down. But she barely felt it, she had never been so agitated, so angry. She couldn’t remember a cold fire raging so hard in her heart since the war. Did the other one… Did her sister know him too Or did she feel this anger and rage that was impossible to control? Now she realized that she wanted to meet her. She hadn't thought much about her before, she had focused more on freeing her from the clutches of the dammed sorcerer than on who she was. From what Glimmer and Adora had said and what she had noticed herself, she was surrounded by

friends she could count on, and who could count on her. It had been many years before she had gotten so close to anyone, not counting Adora. She could say that this girl had come further than she had at her age. But there was also Shadow Weaver with her... Was she telling the truth that she hadn't known this girl until recently? Her sister mentioned that her hand was mutilated by a woman, and everyone knows that the Dark Sorceress was capable of such atrocities. Only, there was also Lady Ka. She had seen for herself that her hand had been replaced with a cybernetic prosthesis. It didn't have to mean anything. Maybe Glimmer was just jumping to conclusions, but she remembered that Lady Ka had almost shot Entrapta, and there was no telling what she had done during her wedding. She could accept the fact that this woman could have hurt her sister, but would her father then allow her to continue working for him? Even if he didn't know what she had done to his second daughter, she must have committed other terrible acts, and that meant that he accepted such people in his fleet... Which in turn would mean... She couldn't let her thoughts wander in that direction, because she could come to conclusions that she didn't have the strength to accept. So she had to believe that the Dark Sorceress was lying in this matter as well. But if not... She couldn't imagine what she would do then. She simply couldn't be betrayed once again. She couldn't bear it. She had to stick to what she had believed to be true until now, because otherwise her world would fall apart, and she would fall into the abyss again. But she couldn't shake the doubt she constantly felt in her heart. In the back of her mind, the question kept coming back, what if this was all true? She knew she wouldn't be able to rest until she found out everything.

She hid her face in her hands, feeling the wind untangling the ponytail in which she usually tied her stiff hair. The ribbon flew somewhere, so her hair fluttered freely. She had to hold on tightly with her feet so that the wind wouldn't throw her off the peak. Melog crouched down next to her, putting his head under her armpit. She hugged him and they stood there for a while, looking blankly at the storm that was beginning to rage around them. Lightning struck next to her, she knew she was taking a risk, but

now she didn't care. She wasn't really thinking about anything, she was just ignoring the biting cold and the thunder that was making her bones shake. Melog didn't radiate any colors, he had his neutral gray-blue color. As always, he was surprisingly pleasant to the touch, and now he was the only source of warmth in this cold world in which she now had to exist. She saw lonely trees, or rather overgrown bushes, bending under the icy wind. She thought her life was similar. Some storms kept coming and crushing her to the ground, but she didn't let them break her.. She always got back up, as hard and strong as before. This time it would be the same, she was sure of it. But what had caused this storm that raged in her heart? Was it the fact that her friends had believed her father's lies, or the suspicion that the accusations were true? She couldn't see, but she had become a lonely tree in the raging wind. She saw lightning strike one of the trees, and it burst into flames. She laughed darkly to herself, and wondered if the truth could be like that lightning, would it burn her soul to ash?

Then she heard someone jump onto the rock next to her.

„Hey Adora.„ She asked immediately knowing Who had come. She felt the warmth radiating from her, Which now brought her relief. Actually, it always brought her relief, only she didn't admit it during war, overcome with anger and hatred. Now she knew, that the power of her beloved, her dearest, the one she had always loved, comes from what is good in her.

"Hey Catra..." Adora said and sat as close to her as she could here. But she had the impression that the wind had died down. Was it just an illusion or another one of She-Ra's powers? She wasn't sure, but that didn't matter now. All that mattered was her proximity. They sat there in silence for a while, ignoring the storm that raged around them.

„I know you always liked to sit on the highest spot possible, but it's a bit cold here and all... You'll catch a cold!„ Her wife said, stroking her head. She turned around and looked into her eyes. She always loved looking into them, regardless of their shade,

which was different depending on the form she was in. Now she was in She-Ra form, but she took off the armor that the Lord Admiral gave her, probably because it might be too heavy to climb such a steep slope.

„Because threats like lightning and the falling from a height of several hundred meters are insignificant?„ she said quietly, and her wife answered.

„You probably haven't seen yourself when you're sick! Rather than dealing with you then, it's better to fight the cosmic tyrants, or working in a quarry.”

„Hey, I'm not that terrible, am I?„ She looked sideways at her beloved.

"You are, you are… Last time the servants who were supposed to bring you medicine drew lots to determine which one would do it." Adora replied, grinning at her. They fell silent again, but the storm was getting more intense, so finally her wife spoke.

„ You know, I think we should really get down from here. “

„Just a moment.„ she answered her quietly, so that her voice could barely be heard over the raging storm.

"But you know that eventually you're going to have to do this and face all of this," Adora said in a more serious voice.

„I know, I can't escape the truth, whatever it is. It's just that it's all so difficult.„ They fell silent again, but after a moment her wife said.

„You know, when I learned the truth about the Horde I was devastated, furious at those who had deceived me so much. But then I found support in how I was raised. Instead of fighting the evil princesses, I fought the evil Horde, it wasn't that big of a difference. I know that I simply swapped enemies, still making the same mistake, seeing the world in black and white. It wasn't just the propaganda we grew up with, or the lies that Shadow Weaver

fed me, but also my anger at those who deceived me. The fact that I had the power of She-Ra didn't really help either. However, when I learned why the sword was created, when I learned Mara's message, I felt much worse. It seemed to me that everything I had done up until now was meaningless, because the only reason for my existence was to activate the Heart of Etheria. For those who created me, I was just a tool. That's when I blamed myself for Angela's death, and things between me and Glimmer got worse... That's when I also believed we were lost for each other. I almost fell when the Heart was activated.”

„You've told me about it more than once.„ She replied quietly to her wife, but she detected it and said.

„Bow once explained to me that you can tell the same story in different ways. Each time you can highlight a different side of it, so that you can draw different conclusions from it. I wanted to show you that I know how you feel. I'm not saying that your father is the way that Saihe painted him, but you should be prepared for him to be different than you've seen him so far. Maybe he will disappoint you, Or maybe he is just plain imperfect, and as Entrapta says, imperfection is beautiful. Mikah or Bow once told me that Adulthood comes when we discover that our parents are just people. I wish everything could be the way you dreamed, we all would, but we won't know the truth until we investigate this matter, or rather we won't be able to if you were stuck here freezing. We have to go down and think about what to do with all this. The dearest one explained to her, hugging her tightly. She snuggled up to her, and despite the thunder and howling wind, she could feel her heart beating. It always soothed her, just as her purring soothed Adora.

„Glimmer is probably mad at me for what I said about her mother. I know it was mean, and she really doesn't envy me for having a family. But she doesn't understand what it's like...” she answered

"She's probably a little angry, I have the impression that she has other worries than a fight with her friend..." her wife said

thoughtfully. She looked at her from under furrowed brows and asked.

„What do you mean?”

Adora hesitated before answering, and then she saw a Silverwing take off from the makeshift landing pad.

„Netossa must have missed her family... „ she said a bit dizzily, and then she realized that the vehicle was not flying towards her kingdom, but towards Castle Crypto. She wasn't sure what it was about, but she felt a deep sense of unease and said to her beloved.

„Okay, let's go down... I have a bad feeling about this. „ And she started running down the steep slope.

He missed. His lady, the adventures he had with her, and everything. He had no idea how it all happened. How on Etheria did he end up on board a spaceship that took him to the Rebel Base, which wouldn't have bothered him much, because he had always wholeheartedly supported all rebellions, except that this one was set against his friends. On the ship, he met Wrongdak and Entrapta, which pleased him, although he had the impression that the inventor princess had ended up here just as accidentally as he had. He had been asked to help Frosta find the kids he had met when he had organized the weddings of Gllimmer and Bow and Adora and Catra. He didn't quite know why he had to do it, but he listened to his She-Ra, after all, he was her loyal mount. Only then did he understand why she was so interested in those kids. All he had to do was look at that Eti's face... Why hadn't they told him that Catra's sister would be in this wedding? Was it a secret? Yes, he was talkative, but not so much that you couldn't trust him with a secret like that, right?

And then Almost everyone forgot about him, except maybe that redhead girl, she still treated him like some fairytale horse. After

all, he was a wonderful mount belonging to She-Ra... He wasn't just a horse! Unfortunately, there was little he could do about it, he was unable to defeat all the rebels by himself. To be honest, he wasn't even sure if he was a guest or prisoner here. The same question also applied to Entapta, although she seemed happy to be back in her old castle. They let her wander freely around the entire camp, and she could even talk to her husband. Unfortunately, the princess inventor was too fascinated by the technology that Catra's sister and her friends had brought with them, so she didn't pay much attention to him. He tried to talk to this Eti as well, but he was a little afraid of her. After she started to consider the possibility of eating him at the first meeting, he thought I was just joking weirdly, but now he wasn't so sure. She generally seemed a bit strange to him, but then again most of his friends were pretty strange, so he guessed he shouldn't bring that up. Eti's girlfriend was Adorable though, although they must have been together for a very short time, because when they first met it didn't seem like they were a couple. He don't understand why Catra made a secret of having a sister. It had recently turned out that she had a father, who in turn had an entire fleet with him, so he guessed the fact that she had a sister wouldn't change much. He had the impression that he was surrounded by some mysteries that he couldn't understand, mainly because no one had had time to explain anything to him. For example, he found out that those kids were accompanied by a sorcerer with scars who looked disturbingly like Shadow Weaver... and then Lilka told him that it was actually Shadow Weaver herself. She was just traveling around Etheria, and no one thought anything of it. He had to inform Adora and Catra and Glimmer that she was here. He had to think of a way to get out of here. Especially since the empress had to be freed. He might not have been a prisoner, but this woman certainly was. As soon as she woke up and realized where she was, she started yelling at everyone present, especially the lizard who had once served with Catra. Then she got tired and just looked at everyone glumly. He felt sorry for her, so he tried to keep her company, for which she seemed grateful. The other lizard, who assured her that he wasn't a dragon at all, apologized very politely and played some recordings on the monitor. They

were movies, he had seen a few when they were on the Icarus, although he had never watched any of them in full. Most of them were subtitled and probably made far outside the empire. Some featured the Saihe themselves, who seemed to be talking about who loved whom and who was betraying whom, and others featured only lizards similar to Catra's old friend, who were constantly trying to kill each other with gangsters or giant bugs... and then Lilka came and started showing cartoon movies about colorful horses talking about friendship and magic. He liked those, but the empress, who looked more and more depressed, not. He understood her, because he himself was feeling more and more depressed. So he wondered how he could escape from here, but another problem arose. When they got there, it turned out that more soldiers from outside the Empire had arrived, who served Eti and Catra's uncle, who, however, didn't really like the father of both girls, which started to remind him of those Saihe movies...He had dealt with the old rebels once, when they were still serving in the Horde, but these, they looked like they could really make a stew out of him, they wouldn't feel guilty about it. Maybe it had something to do with the fact that Eti's uncle was in charge... Catra didn't seem to want to eat him even at her worst. So now he had to wait and watch for an opportunity to escape. The biggest problem, however, was Lilka.

„Please, Mr. Horsee, these are apples!„ she handed him some apples, they smelled quite nice.

„Oh, thank you.„ he said and ate one, then thought about it and asked. „Where do you guys get your apples from?”

„We took some supplies, but we can also print them in the food printer... „ replied the red-haired girl, smiling proudly.

„What do you print them from?„ he asked carefully, slowly chewing the fruit.

„You know, Mr. Horsee, I don't think you'd like to know. These aren't things that are better to think about.„ she answered him, smiling, but also looking at him pleadingly. He looked at the

Apples, they looked really tasty, so he decided that he really wouldn't think about it. Sometimes it was better not to know. Lilka was always nearby when she wasn't cooking or beating up other rebels, because that was her training. It started with them being together most of the time, which made planning an escape much more difficult. Especially since the girl was able to appear at the most surprising moments. She was also able to always track down where he was. She claimed that it was a great orcish tracking technique, although the lizard called Alatar claimed that it was simply Lilka's sense. Either way, there was no way he wasn't able to do it properly. On top of that, the Empress began to sulk even more, and cooperation with her became impossible.

But there was another reason he didn't quite want to run away. It was, for example, the fact that for the first time in years he had his mane brushed. It mean, there was always someone doing his hair, but it was rarely someone who enjoyed it so much. He couldn't hide the fact that it was very pleasant, and the red-haired girl also brushed him and brought him treats. At first he didn't understand why she was so fascinated by him. It mean, he wasn't surprised, because after all, he was a winged unicorn, the steed of the famous She-Ra! People usually admired him, at least at first, because later... it was different. But for now it seemed that Lilka's delight was not waning, but he began to wonder why she was so interested in taking care of him, so he finally asked her.

„I've never met anyone who liked horses so much.”

He was in the main salon of the ship, and everyone present, namely Alatar, Captain Bina, and Eti, gave him warning glances. What were they on about? It was just a simple logical question. That's when Lilka froze for a moment, and her gaze glazed over, and then she said, peeling an apple.

„Because you see, once upon a time there was a girl named Lilka, and she lived on a farm, and there they had horses, and other animals. And she took care of everyone.„ She spoke, and although she tried to be cheerful, there was something strange in her voice, as if it was empty…

„And that girl, that Lilka, was it you, right?„ He asked, sure that he had guessed the meaning of the girl's story, but she looked at him angrily and screamed.

„No! She was a completely different girl! She was weak and defenseless! She couldn't defend her family from the Swarm! She's gone! She's been reforged, nothing is left of her! Now there's only Lilka the orc! Strong and Undefeated!„ She closed her eyes and breathed for a moment, and he tried to understand what had just happened. Finally the girl said in a slightly calmer voice.

„You know, Mr. Horsee, you're the second stupidest person on this ship after Ireannis, and now you're going to be the first, because Ireanis is going somewhere with the Queen's mom, so you're going to be the stupidest.”

What she said sounded very… strange, but she seemed to be absolutely serious, so he said it very carefully.

„But you know that's impossible because Queen Glimmer's mother is dead, right?”

Lilka shook her head as if he had said something very wise to me, and explained.

„Of course she's alive! We've all talked to her! She's not even a vampire, or anything like that, I know because I know about that, I talked to a vampire, and Eti became friends with his daughter. I think they even dated.„ she looked at the cat girl, who gave her a very strange look, and Rosie blinked a few times. I'll look at the rest we'll mix and asked.

„But she's making it up, right? I mean, you were wrong, right?”

Eti shook her head and said.

„Captain Wingy is the mother of the witch queen, but she is much nicer than her. She does not want to imprison people without a reason, unless they are Azlantii.”

He jumped to his feet and shouted.

„Someone has to tell the Queen and her father and everyone, fast!„ For a moment he thought of running outside and flying away towards Brightmoon, but he realized that he probably wouldn't be allowed to do that.

"How to put it... I think the Queen already knows about it, because somehow Captain Moonshadow tried to kill Adora and bomb the city in the process. „ Bina answered him, and when he looked at her in disbelief, Eti added.

„ But now it's all right, and he almost doesn't want to kill anyone. But that will change, and he'll help me kill my father. Don't worry hoofy, everything's all right."

He looked at first not understanding what he had learned, but then it dawned on him, and he understood everything. No one saw fit to inform him of all this. He was slowly starting to get used to being away from his Lady, but now he realized he had been pushed outside the circle of people she trusted. Secrets were not shared with him, as if they could not be trusted, or it did not matter. He felt sad, almost betrayed. He lowered his head and put his wings down. He stood like that for a long time, until finally the ship began to take off. Lilka approached and began to comb his hair, noticing that he was sad. Suddenly he felt something familiar, a great power that had accompanied him since his mind had awakened. He focused, so he tried to make contact... Contact with the one who had given him intelligence and awareness of who he was. Awareness that he was. Without her, he would still be an ordinary horse, Who led a simple, perhaps happy life, but would never become who he is, and he was very happy with who he is. It didn't matter that his friends forgot about him, that they didn't consider him trustworthy enough to entrust him with secrets. He forgave them, because I know that's what friendship is. So he focused, and tried to connect with the one in which he had a bond that only the two of them could understand.

"Is it normal for his horn to glow?" Bina asked.

She jumped rather than walked down the mountainside. Adora kept pace with her, as did Melog, though her companion glanced around warily, as if to be careful for all three of them They quickly reached the military camp, where the guards did not even try to stop them.. Inside, however, she had to stop and think for a moment who she should go to. On the one hand, he said to talk to Glimmer now, because maybe she knew why the Silverwing had taken off. However, it would be quicker if she got to the landing pad, where she could find out what exactly had happened faster. She stood there thinking for a moment, and then she heard someone walking towards her and calling.

„Hey Catra!”

She looked in that direction and saw Starla, Tallstar, and some ginger boy.

"Excuse me, but I really don't have time for idle chitchat! A lot has happened recently, and now I need to quickly find out why Netossa flew away and where exactly, so please don't interrupt!" She said sharply, feeling irritated at being bothered at such a time. The sisters looked at each other, and then Tallstar said.

„So that's what Frosta meant...”

She looked at older sister, feeling fear for her little friend.

„What are you on about? Tell me! But quickly!

Tallstar hesitated, looking at her carefully, then spoke slowly and carefully.

Frosta said she wanted to meet your sister. I think it's about that girl we met in a certain monastery…”

“And who wanted to eat Glory! „ Starla chimed in and petted the shiny owl sitting on her shoulder ha ha

She stared at the gray-skinned women for a few moments, then leapt at Tallstar with her claws outstretched. She knocked her to the ground and grabbed her tightly by the lapels of her uniform.

„How could you be so stupid as to let her go alone! Don't you know what happened to her!„ she screamed in her face, feeling the rage heat up in her heart again.

„She's a grown girl, not to mention that she's a princess. We couldn't stop her, and besides, we didn't know what she wanted to do!„ The oldest sister grabbed her wrists with her cybernetic hands and pushed her away. „ Besides, I think General Netossa and Princess Mermista have already taken care of the matter. We told them everything."

Melog began to radiate blue as she felt horror grip her heart. Frosta went to Lonnie, where Shadow Weaver was waiting for her. How could they be so stupid, so thoughtless, to let her go, especially in her condition. What that soldier lied to hurt her so much that she couldn't handle it and decided to run away. She probably thought she was just as much of a monster as the Dark Sorceress. She was breathing heavily, spasmodically clenching her hands, and her wife embraced her and said.

„Forgive her, but Frosta is in a really bad condition, and she shouldn't make such decisions, because... then you don't have a clear mind, and it can end badly... „ she tried to sound calm, although she could see she was just as scared as she was.

"Yeah, I get it, everyone loses their temper sometimes," Tallstar said, crossing her arms over her chest.

„We have to do something, we have to stop her. „ She said quietly to herself, and rubbed her face with her hands. She knew what she should do. She should go to Glimmer, and tell her to go after Frosta. But then there would be questions, and everything would most likely turn into another discussion, and she didn't have time for that now! Besides, she still felt angry... and ashamed towards her friend. As the Grand Marshal, she could order any ship to take

her to any place she ordered, unless Glimmer forbade it. It was unlikely, but... There was a storm now, and most of Etheria's ships did not have avionics good enough to fly in such a hurricane. They were not undetectable either... unlike others, whose owners she could also command...

„I have an idea Adora! „ she called to her wife and ran to the place where her father's soldiers had decided.

The soldiers serving in the Fearless Armada saluted her, except for Lady Ka's subordinates, who at best greeted her with a nod, more often ignored her. Finally, she reached the large transport ship located in the center of this makeshift camp. She was trying in frustration to find someone who was competent enough to know where the commander of this place was, when she heard a voice

„So the young one ran away again, huh?„ said Lady Ka, who approached her surrounded by her soldiers. There was a signal with her a short bearded man, with a cybernetic leg and hand leg, and an insectoid from the same people as Ashurk, However, looking much more competent.

"How do you know? It doesn't matter. You will give me your ships and your men and come with me. This is my order and I demand that you carry it out." She said sharply, not wanting to argue with the woman whose single eye had a predatory glint.

„You demand, you say... If you demand it, what can I do? I will gladly fulfill this request.„ she said, not stopping smiling strangely. She knew this kind of smiles and knew that they did not herald anything good.

Adora looked at the Half-Masked Woman anxiously, then said.

„Um, I'm not sure if that's a good idea. kitty, it would be better if you talked to Glimmer, she might be a little mad at you, but in this situation she'll forget about it, I'm sure. But Frosta...„ she said, And suddenly she touched her temple with two fingers, and groaned.

„Is something wrong?„ she asked, worried about her beloved's health.

„Nothing, but I feel like Swiftwind wants to contact me using our bond. He did it once before when we saved Glimmer... I can sense him and... He's not flying towards Dryl, he's flying north.”

She looked in that direction and understood. The last time they were in the lost City of Lonnie she was looking for something there, not just that part, but something else. She hadn't thought about it until now, but there were ruins of the First Ones in that place. Could Shadow Weaver be looking for something there? Lady Cala led Adora to the ruins of the First Ones located underneath, and there the crazy AI wanted to Kill her. This could mean something very dangerous, maybe she had discovered another ancient weapon in those ruins, she wanted to recover it and Use it against the inhabitants of Etheria...

„I think I know what she's up to. I... I have to go and I'll try to stop her, and you Convince Glimmer to send us a support force where we're going. Thanks to your bond with Swiftwind, you'll know better where I'm going.... Tell Glimmer that Shadow Weaver is looking for something in the ruins of the First Ones...” She said and kissed her beloved's lips as tenderly as she could, then she looked at Lady Ka.

"When will you be ready to leave?" she asked the woman in the trap, and she answered.

„You're the Lord Admiral's daughter, and your word is my command. We can take off in half an hour.”

"That's good, but you warn your people that this may be an extremely dangerous mission," she said, but Lady Ka chuckled.

„ Believe me, they are not afraid of any dangers, because I have made sure that they fear me more than the most terrible enemy.” she said, smiling colder than the gusts of storm wind.

Chapter End Notes

And again you've waited for a new chapter, but I hope you'll like it. Please leave comments and opinions..

What was torn apart will be reunited

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Do you remember, brother, that I still hate outdoor trips?" said his sister, and he smiled at her crookedly.

„Yes, I remember our wonderful camping trip. You got lost... sixteen times? Actually, seventeen. But that one time. You got lost when we were walking back together, so that counts as one time.„ he said and laughed, but Casta snorted in irritation and replied.

„I remember my parents telling me that you got lost in the basement and you cried because you couldn't get out!„ she looked at him triumphantly. He rolled his eyes and replied.

„Remember, our basement was so big it stretched under our entire family estate. You could cram an entire village in there and no one would notice."

„In fact, we once crammed an entire village there.. You were already in school then, so you don't remember. It was at the very beginning of the war, when the Horde entered the lands of our kingdom. The lands of the Grand Duchy of Lotus, that is.„ She threw a significant look at Hordak, and then continued. „ All the people from the surrounding villages sought shelter in our manor. We hid in the basement among the wine barrels, and then we tried to wait it out. The soldiers stole half of the wine barrels, but my parents were still happy, because most of them were full of the worst drink anyway, you know the one for cooking. When they left, for a while, everything went back to normal, but then... Well, I moved to Mystacor, and my parents moved to Brightmoon. They always missed their old life, and I guess they were never really happy in their new place."

Hordak looked at them confused and said.

„ I'm sorry about what happened, but I didn't know that soldiers stole wine during the war.. Alcohol was prohibited in the Fright Zone.”-`

She and her sister looked at him, unsure how to react to what he said.

„You may have decreed prohibition, but that doesn't mean there was no black market there. To this day, the moonshine of the technical department is known to all of Etheria ... You didn't know about it?„ he said finally. When he saw the confusion on the face of the former ruler of the Horde, he added in surprise. „Did you really not know about anything?„ he did not hide the surprise in his voice.

„ What do you think Shadow Weaver was drinking? „ His sister asked, smiling indulgently. Hordak looked down and said slowly.

„I knew she got alcohol from somewhere. She tried to hide it, but I always knew about it. Sometimes she took these Mint lozenges, which were supposed to mask the smell of alcohol, but it didn't work very well. I liked the smell, those lozenges because it reminded me of the disinfectant used on the Velvet Glove. It irritated me that she drank, but there was nothing I could do about it. I needed her, without her I wouldn't be able to manage the Horde...„ he said quietly, looking into the flames of the campfire. It was evening, the bright moons had already set, and the stars scattered the sky. They stopped a few hours ago in the Valley of Shattered Armor. It was strange to just camp here. He saw wrecks of vehicles everywhere, as well as armor and weapons. Most of the bodies had been buried after the war, but some of them were still in hidden or inaccessible places. A strange, ominous Aura hovered over the entire area. He didn't believe in ghosts before, but after what he had experienced on the Beast Island, what he had read in the ancient books and, most importantly, after what his own sister had told him about those strange events in the underground of Mystacor. Their family

had kept many old stories and practices that had been practically forgotten in other parts of the planet. Or so he thought, because the more he got to know Etheria, the more he discovered how diverse and full of secrets it was. For example, in his everyday home they had an altar to honor their ancestors, something that was not known in many places on the planet, although he was surprised to discover that this Practice was known in many worlds, especially on Icarus. He never managed to tell Glimmer about it. She was too young before he was sent to the Beast Island, and then... Somehow the right moment wasn't there. Maybe it would be easier for her to accept the death of her Mother... Although she is alive, another of the miracles he has experienced in his life. He didn't know when or how he would meet her, But he was willing to do anything to get them back together, who, apart from his daughter, he loved the most in the world. Once he explored these ruins. However, he learned that it would be much more complicated than he had expected so far.

When they reached the Valley, they set up camp. The former lord of the Horde was helping him in this task, which was a bit surprising. He never thought he would be doing absolutely anything with this guy, and certainly not setting up camp. He also didn't think someone like Hordak would know anything about surviving in the wild. He didn't hesitate to ask him about it, after talking about his knowledge of the alcohol trade in the horror zone, he asked.

„For someone who 's spent most of his life confined to a lab, you're doing pretty well in the wild.”

The clone looked at him and snorted.

„I have many skills. Horde Prime put a lot of knowledge into our heads during our conditioning, because we were supposed to be His perfect soldiers, but also servants. We were elite troops, and each of you should be able to take care of everything. We all have technical skills, I just developed them, because I needed them. But equally, Each of us knows how to handle the wild, because it was necessary during the wars for Horde Prime. We can even

cook, if any of us were forced to make dinner for our Big Brother. This is quite useful, because Entrapta, despite this brilliant mind, is a complete culinary talentless.”

Castaspellla looked at the clone in surprise and said.

“I hope Shadow Weaver arrives soon and we won't have to test your cooking skills.”

Then he saw Hordak hesitate , even look guilty. For a moment he seemed to struggle with his thoughts, and then he answered.

"Shadow Weaver won't be coming. I spoke to my wife few days ago, and she told me that Shadow Weaver had been captured during the wedding. That's why I was detained. Your daughter suspected that I might be in on the case," he said in a quiet voice, as if he were embarrassed. They both stared at him open-mouthed, until his sister finally stood up and put her hands on her hips and screamed.

„And you've been hiding it from us this whole time! How could you do this! How are we supposed to trust you now, not that we trusted you before!”

Hordak looked at them smiling grimly and said.

„If I had told you earlier, you might have decided to turn around and deal with her yourself, or do something equally senseless, Instead of focusing on our task..”

„And rightly so! This is our family after all! We have to help her, or else…!„ his sister yelled, but he interrupted her.

„He's right... „ He said looking into the flames, and his sister looked at him in disbelief, so he explained „If we knew that Shadow Weaver was imprisoned, we would have turned back, but little would come of it.. Now it's Glimmer's business, as well as Catra and Adora. Especially Catra and Adora. They have a greater right to question this woman. I have nothing to tell her, nothing new. Maybe it's even better. I prefer her to be under lock and key,

watched by those who will definitely not be fooled by her manipulations, and personally I prefer to cooperate with this strange sorceress. She may be a bit weird, but she definitely doesn't look like someone capable of deceiving, and manipulating others. Besides, it might be interesting to talk about the magical arts practiced in distant corners of the Galaxy.„ He smiled at Castaspelia . Now the argument was rather directed at her, because he himself was no longer so interested in the mysterious arts, he had other matters that occupied his thoughts.

„Shadow Weaver is less of a problem than Catra's father... My wife is with that Lonnie's Rebels, along with my brother, and that stupid horse. The Lord Admiral's other daughter is with her too... Entrapta said that one of that Antares' subordinates tried to kill her, and I don't trust anyone else like I trust her. She always tries to see the good in others... If she says someone is evil, then they must be really mean.„ Hordak explained, stirring the soup that is supposed to be their dinner in a pot.

„You should have said that too!„ Castaspella shouted.

„Perhaps I should, but I doubt your daughter would believe me, and certainly not her friends I understand that after all these years I have not earned the right to have anyone trust my word, even when I tell the truth.„ The former Horde commander looked at him, smiling bitterly. He closed his eyes, sighed and nodded.

„You're right about that too. No one would believe him, and we only have Shadow Weaver's words behind us. To tell the truth, I don't know why I believe everything she says. I suspect that she hides a lot of things from us anyway. The knowledge she gathered while she was still in Mystacor ... And also outside of it... She has a patron, a being she summoned during that ritual.„ He spoke thoughtfully, but Hordak snorted and said.

„She always liked having someone above her, someone she could control and use to increase her own power. I almost feel sorry for that someone, because he himself has become just a tool in her games.

He shook his head and answered the clone.

„If this is the being I read about... Even she wouldn't deceive someone like that. Nyarlathotep... Rather, the Devourer of Light is an unimaginably old and powerful creature. Compared to someone like that, even your brother was like... like a mayfly facing a dragon.„ when he said this, he felt a growing fear. And what if they were now carrying out the will of the being that was the true master of Shadow Weaver. He remembered that power he felt during the ritual. Not only power, but evil that could not be described with words. As a student, he had searched for some mentions of this creature, but he had only found rumors and empty speculations. Only after the war, thanks to his daughter fathers-in-laws, he had found a book that touched on the subject of Nyarlathotep . However, until now he had only thought that these were secrets that he should investigate, but he had assumed that their discovery so quickly would prove to be so important for his life, and the lives of his loved ones. He knew that he had only seen the tip of an iceberg, made of the black ice of dark secrets, whose cold horror shocked the soul through and through. He had not found much evidence that this being, this Nyarlathetop, was actually operating on Etheria, and he was not even sure if he was anything more than a magical parasite, after all he could not fully trust his memory, nor what was written in the book. Memories are distorted, and books can contain lies and assumptions unsupported by facts. But something deep in his heart told him that all this was true. That with the dark sorceress a great evil had come to Etheria. He looked around. Above his head the stars and moons shone brightly. There was something calming in this sight, although at the same time overwhelming, which should not have been surprising, because after all he could now admire the vastness of the universe, despite the fact that he had only seen a small fragment of it. After all, they were just an insignificant speck of dust that the Wind would leave to blow away. He wondered if the fact that the stars had been unknown to them for all these centuries had made them value the life of every creature so highly?

His companions didn't take kindly to what he was saying. Hordak snorted in contempt, and his sister didn't even say a word, swatting away at the insects. He smiled sadly, envying their unawareness and lack of worries. Perhaps, at least for a while, he should give up thinking about such gloomy issues, but then he looked around. Although darkness covered the valley, you had the impression that he saw something there. Perhaps not exactly material things, but an aura of ghastly evil. Was it released by a spell cast by Shadow Weaver, or maybe it was caused by the deaths of thousands of soldiers from both sides who gave their lives here during that battle. Or maybe it was all simply caused by memories that distorted how he perceived this place. However, if there can be such beings as the one summoned by Shadow Weaver... Or like the not-dead who wanted to kill his sister. And he still felt this aura, even intensified by his earlier thoughts. When he looked to the side he sometimes saw them moving, in the silence that followed their conversation he heard nothing but the creaking of burning wood. Maybe it was just the Wind blowing among the bare rocks, In which the walls of the valley had become after the spell cast by the dark sorcerer, but he thought he heard wailing and moaning. He looked at his companions. Castaspella seemed to notice nothing, but Hordak looked worried. For a moment he wondered if he shouldn't ask him somewhere, if he sensed something strange, but he had reservations. It was strange, but he didn't want to come across as a superstitious inhabitant of a backwater planet in front of someone like that. Since when did he care about the opinion of someone like him? It was stupid, after all Hordak was nothing to him. Maybe he was simply afraid to voice his fears out loud… Only, was he silent because he was ashamed that his fears were absurd, or because if he voiced them out loud, he would have to start taking them seriously. Something deep in his heart told him that these were not ordinary childish fears, the unreasonable fears of someone who had returned to the place where his life had been broken. What had happened then when the Dark Sorceress had cast the spell that had led to the deaths of So many… Such powerful, and such terrible magic could not fail to leave its mark on the surroundings. The power that had been unleashed then was the

greatest that had been seen on all of Etheria for centuries. He had never heard of such a spell before, and perhaps its casting would not have been possible without the help of Black Garnet … Although he had become the head sorcerer of Mystacor, he had never equaled your former master in knowledge.

The thoughtful silence was broken by Hordak.

„There's something wrong with this place. I don't like it.”

Castaspella snorted with contempt.

„Because it reminds you of your crimes! Let's not kid ourselves, most of those who died here were your fault.„ she said sharply, throwing the former ruler of the Horde an accusing look. But he endured it and calmly responded.

„It's not about that... it's not just about that. This place... It brings to mind Shadow Weaver... I spent time with her too, that I could sense her approaching. Her power left a certain aftertaste... it even had a smell... This place was marked by her, corrupted . She marked it with her own presence. I spent the last few years on The Beast Island. That place was also corrupted by the Great Power, although in a different way. „ He looked him straight in the eye. He nodded, agreeing , to his surprise, with his old sworn enemy...

"Yeah, I was going to cleanse this place up before all this happened," he explained, rubbing his chin thoughtfully.

„Cleanse? From what?„ she asked his sister in surprise.

„From the evil that has settled here.„ he said and looked his sister seriously in the eye. And then he began to tell her about the stories that circulated about this place.„ People say that hungry shadows prowl here, who can suck the strength out of their touch. Others talk about terrible creatures, with bodies similar to humans, but with powerful fangs and claws. They supposedly hunt not only animals, but also intelligent beings... And I've heard

worse stories, since with a body inside, who suck blood with their long tongues.

Castaspella shuddered when she heard his story, then said irritably.

"Sounds like one of those horrible scary stories you'd tell around a campfire. I hated them... They were another reason I still hate camping." She shuddered again.

And then it happened. First he felt a power, similar to what appeared when his daughter used her teleportation power. This time, however, it was a bit... Softer, more like waves of power than the violent explosion that accompanied his daughter's appearance. Then he saw a pink-purple flash clearly visible in the darkness. He jumped to his feet , and preparing a spell, he ran towards where he saw a flash of light. It was clearly not Shadow Weaver, but he wasn't sure who. It was definitely not his daughter, even though the power was similar. It radiated something familiar, just like the magic permeating the Valley, it had something of a dark sorcerer in it. He felt an unexpected excitement, a sudden burst of hope, because he remembered now well where he had given such power. But, was it possible? Ignoring the voices of his companions, he was there in a few bounds. There was a clearing of vitrified sand, surrounded by several low hills, on which there were many military equipment, even one tank. But it did not matter to him, because He saw her! She was standing there! She looked different. She was dressed in a dark purple cloak. Her hair was cut short, the visible part of her face was covered with golden tattoos, and the rest was covered by a mask of blue crystal. With horror and despair, he saw that their wings were resting on a metal frame, and their right arm had been replaced with a cybernetic prosthesis... But it was her! The woman he loved more than life! It was love for her that allowed him to survive all these years in exile. If it weren't for her, they would have allowed themselves to be devoured by the island long ago... So he stood there, staring at his beloved. He fell to his knees Unable to utter a single word, he fell to his knees, and He stared at Angela, at his Angie … Tears streamed down his face, on

which a joyful, though probably somewhat unconscious smile appeared. Angela looked at him , and I don't think she recognized him at first, she just looked around with confusion, but then understanding appeared in her eyes. She took a step back, she seemed terrified. But why? After all… After all, after so many years, they were finally together. He loved her, and she loved him, that was the truth… That was the truth? He felt a sudden fear and, having gathered himself, he said in a breaking voice.

„Angie it's me, Mikah ...”

She touched her face with her living hand. Tears welled in her beautiful pink”purple eyes. She pressed her maimed wings to her body, as she always did when she was scared or confused.

„ Oh, Mikah … By the devils and demons, it's really you… You're alive. All these years… I thought you were dead, I didn't even remember your face. And now… And now you're standing here in front of me… Please tell me you're alive… That it's really you, and not some ghost or doppelganger … That I didn't imagine you were here with me…„ She knelt down before him and took off her mask. She was just as beautiful as always, just as he remembered . He moved to her and embraced her, she squeezed his arms and wings. He felt her warmth, her scent… In that moment he felt like the happiest man in the world.

„I love you so much... „ he whispered quietly.

She wasn't yet well acquainted with her new power... The first time she used it was in the monastery, when she took Bina to her charges. She had seen that she could do it before, it was simply something instinctive that she could do without even thinking about it, a bit like walking or speaking. She had simply been unaware of it all these years, only when she approached this region of the Galaxy, some of her powers began to awaken, as if she was only now realizing what she was truly capable of. The second time she used It was when she was running away from

that aristocrat, of a monstrous nature. Then she practiced it several times on the ship, but always at a very short distance. Now, for the first time, she managed to use it, at such a considerable distance. Despite everything, she believed that it was a safer way than using that Elf's spell. That woman was full of enthusiasm, but even She doubted her abilities. However, it didn't change the fact that She was afraid of the results of her teleportation.

But all four of them were there. Above them were the stars shining, and those strange moons, did she really have to be on a planet with twelve moons? It must have been nightmarish if you were a Werewolf… She shook her head, to get rid of the strange thoughts, and then looked around. At first glance, she noticed that they were on an old battlefield. She saw destroyed vehicles everywhere, and abandoned weapons. She didn't see any corpses anywhere yet, they were probably buried a long time ago. However, she immediately sensed that something was wrong with this place. A strange aura hovered over this place , sending shivers down her spine. It reminded her of that monastery, where they fought the horde and the dead and the shadows… But there was something else that made her uneasy. This place brought back memories, terrible memories, full of despair and sadness. She wasn't sure if she'd ever been here in person, but she'd definitely recognized this Valley from stories. That's why when she saw the fire, she'd reflexively summoned a Solarian flare, and Tonado had drawn his blades. And then she'd seen the man running toward her. He wasn't young anymore, but he still seemed to be in good shape, considering how fast he'd run toward her. He'd held a sorcerer's staff in his hands, making it easier for him to run through you, and the remnants, and the battles. And then he'd stood before her, and she'd seen who he was. Memories flooded her mind. Their first meeting. Conversations under a strange purple sky. Their first kiss. Their wedding. How they'd played together with their little daughter. They'd all come at once, hitting her mind like a sword's blade. They were fragmented, and without context, but... it was still so much more than she'd had so far. She'd realized who she was, and she'd stepped back,

understanding just how much of a person she'd become. She was a monster, a terrible pirate, a scourge on Azlanti… Because she had dozens, perhaps hundreds of lives on my conscience. True, they were not innocent inhabitants of the Galaxy, and for the most part servants of an oppressive empire, but not all. She was cruel and ruthless. She had blood on her hands. She stepped back, terrified of herself, but he still He gazed at her with love He knelt before her and uttered the Words

„Angie , it's me, Mikah”

She touched her face with her hand, and then she felt, for the first time in so many years, that she was crying. She was glad that most of her crew were not here. She did not want them to see her, in such a moment of weakness. She expected him to see it, but she could believe it. It was simply that it could be true, it had to be a lie or a deception, such things did not happen to people like her. People like her did not deserve such happiness... But she also knew that it could not be anyone else. She simply could not accept her happiness, so she said.

„Oh, Mikah … By the devils and demons, it's really you… You're alive. All these years… I thought you were dead, I didn't even remember your face. And now… And now you're standing here in front of me… Please tell me you're alive… That it's really you, and not some ghost or doppelganger … That I didn't imagine you were here with me…

She knelt before him, and then And then she took off her mask. The air around her had become dry, burning her throat and lungs… It was a dry place, And soon she would have to put her mask back on, Or she would start to choke, and eventually suffocate. But now She wanted to show her face to the one who was so important.

„I love you so much.„ he whispered hugging her tightly. She hugged her back and for a moment they knelt like that, forgetting about the whole world. But then she saw Him, the tyrant and

invader, the one who brought war to her world. She felt anger and rage burst into black flames in her heart.

Chapter End Notes

Well, here's another chapter. I think I made a mistake in the Failures chapter, which I'll fix.

Unavenged Grudges

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

As soon as he saw the former king running towards the flash of light, he jumped to his feet and transformed one arm into a weapon. He wasn't sure who had appeared here. Reason told him that it was the effect of this Saihe using a spell , but he couldn't stop the reflexes that had been implanted in him right after he came into the world. He had never trusted magic, as well the people who used it, and this place made him feel alert, like in a war zone. Wherever he looked, he saw traces of the destructive effects of magic. Wrecked vehicles, and abandoned equipment, it was all the work of one person who cast one spell. On his orders, of course, or at least with his approval. He shouldn't be a hypocrite. He was briefly a soldier in Horde Prime's army, but he saw cities burned. He helped destroy them, then and later.. But there was something against the laws of nature in this place. Magic had warped the entire area, marking it with its darkness. It was like radioactive contamination, it would exist long after he died.

Saihe appeared, but she wasn't alone. He felt a sudden surge of suspicion that he had acquired during his reign in the Fright Zone. Was this a trap set by Shadow Weaver? It would be her style to take advantage of their trust and then betray them. But then, thanks to his eyes capable of seeing in the dark, he saw Who had arrived and realized that this was a trap, although only for him. In addition to this strange Saihe, he saw three people, but he recognized only one of them, and only she mattered here. Queen Angela... He had never seen her up close, but he knew she had changed a lot, but she still had that which had kept her leading the rebellion against his Horde for so many years. For a moment, she and her husband began, hugging and crying. He remembered

a similar moment right after his brother had been defeated, when he met Entrapta again . After being chiped, as well as the purification procedures, his mind was clouded at that time, but after meeting his love, he still felt that he was burning with an indescribable happiness. Even if he already had a feeling that he would have to face the consequences of his actions, it still didn't matter to him at the time, all that mattered was the joy of being together with the most wonderful woman in the world again. Now the former king felt the same, although their future would probably not be strewn with so many complications... Or maybe not, after everything they had learned recently, no one could predict what awaited them. He smiled , and tried to prepare himself for what was about to come. And then Queen Angela saw him. Even from this distance he could see the rage in her eyes. She stood up, pushing her husband away and took two steps towards him.

“It's you!” she shouted and one of her hands was once again enveloped in cold blue flame. A strange hairy creature with many hands drew many blades, which in all of its hands, and a small person in strange, as if organic armor looked at him and clenched a fist, which began to transform into a weapon. Only the strange sorceress seemed confused. He sighed, and bowed his head.

“Hail, Queen... Do what you must...” He said resignedly

He should have expected that something similar would eventually happen to him. Finally, someone would want to bring him closer to the justice he deserved for everything he had done during his life. He just didn't think it would be her, the former leader rebels , his old enemy, but maybe that's a good thing! For so many years they fought against each other, although they had never met. Now they would stand face to face, and finally the queen would get the revenge she had been waiting for then. He didn't feel sorry for himself, he knew he hadn't gotten the punishment he deserved, so he didn't resist now. He only felt sorry for his wife and child, that they would be sad after his death. He could only hope that they would understand and come to terms with what had happened to him instead of holding a grudge. He wanted to

close his eyes, reconciled with his fate, but he changed his mind. It would be cowardice, unworthy of both him and the Queen. He looked into her eyes. Angela raised her hand and aimed at him, but then, to his immense surprise, Micah covered him.

„He is with us, don't hurt him.”

The woman stopped and looked at him in surprise.

„Step back, he is… You know who he is… He's the reason I lost my life.. He invaded Our World. He's the reason… He's the reason I am who I am. If it weren't for him, none of this would have happened to me.„ she said and coughed.

"He has a wife and a child. They are very good people. If you hurt him, you hurt them too, and they don't deserve that." He shouted, not taking his eyes off the former queen.

„I had a child… and a husband. Because of him I lost it… I lost both of you!„ Angela replied sharply.

„But you got us back! You don't have to take revenge.„ her husband replied.

„But thousands of mothers and fathers, wives and husbands lost their loved ones because of him. How many families did he destroy?„ She screamed, trembling.

„Please , he wants to atone for his sins. He wasn't entirely responsible for his actions... He... I was also a prisoner of Horde Prime. He chipped me. I know how it is. I was ready to hurt our daughter then. I wanted to hurt Glimmer! And he went through conditioning. His mind... he was shattered... „ Micah continued to defend him. His sister, however, watched the whole situation with her arms crossed. That strange sorceress took a bag of crisps out of her pouch, which was definitely too to fit in such a pouch. The strange creature with sabers, continued to look at him menacingly, and that girl in armor looked at him thoughtfully. When Micah mentioned conditioning, the queen hesitated, and

then that girl approached her, and grabbed her by the burning hand.

„Madam Captain, don't do this. It will kill part of you. Now... Now you don't have to think about Revenge anymore, you can... We can all change... Madam Captain, you can forget what happened... We've all taught many terrible things, but now we can stop. Please...„ She said in a voice coming from a speech synthesizer. The Queen looked at her in surprise, but she extinguished and lowered her hand.

„Fine... You'll live, but remember that you're only alive because two people I love stood up for you... Appreciate it.„ she said in a hoarse voice and let out a dry cough, after which she put her mask back on. The tension instantly subsided, and to his surprise he felt relief. He didn't want to die, he liked his new life with his Wife and Child. For the first time since he can remember... for the first time in his life he felt happy, and he didn't want to lose it. He wanted to atone for his sins, but not through His death. He could do so much more. He could fix the wrong he had done. It would be much better than dying pointlessly in the middle of nowhere. He took a deep breath, He realized that only now he allowed himself to take a deeper breath.

The Queen pointed to the creature and the girl and introduced them.

„These are my companions, First Mate Tonado and My Chief Navigator Tirin.

Micah looked at the girl in the strange outfit with surprise and said.

„ We've met before. I just thought you were... That you were one of those people who imprisoned... my wife....„ he threw the queen a questioning look, but Tirin answered.

„But I am Azlanti, As I told you. I am not proud of what the Star Empire is doing, and I am very sorry for everything my people did

to the Captain... that mean, the Queen... „ she looked down, Clearly feeling Guilty. Queen Angela walked up to her and put her hand on her shoulder, and he had the impression that she smiled, although he could only tell by her eyes, and he had never been good at judging other people's behavior by their facial expressions, and she said.

„Tirin helped me free myself from the Azlantean labor camp. If it weren't for her, I probably wouldn't be alive anymore. She sacrificed a lot for me, and she's as close to me as... A daughter.”

The girl in the strange uniform looked at her with a look that seemed to be both surprised and delighted. Micah looked at the girl thoughtfully, then extended his hand to her.

„We've known each other for some time, but only now do we know who we are, so we can say hello again. It's nice to meet you Tirin. „ he said, and the navigator carefully likes his gloved hand, and said through the synthesizer.

“It's nice to meet you too, King... King Consort...„ The girl was clearly confused.

„Just call me Micah , it's for the best... „ he said, smiling reassuringly at Tirin, and then said to his wife.

„I think you should come to our bonfire... I didn't prepare much because I didn't know you were coming. Up until now I thought only Shadow Weaver would come and of course Mrs.... Ireanis, and Hordak's former right hand supposedly could live practically on alcohol alone.„ the former king laughed nervously, as if it was some kind of joke, but then the creature named Tonado said

„Luckily I brought with me special self-heating rations of good Akitonian production, in case my captain turns out to be hungry... I took two weeks' supplies for the captain.„ he looked at the king with complete seriousness, turning up his nose a little.

„I have to eat my food anyway because... My digestive system doesn't work very well and I wouldn't be able to eat normal

things.„ Tirin explained, and then That stupid Elf joined the conversation.

„And I have crisps! Desirable, healthy, just only preservatives and flavor enhancers.„ She waved a bag of some snacks in front of them. The Queen shrugged, the atmosphere relaxed and everyone seemed to be in a good mood, even him. But immediately he felt a shiver run down his spine. Something was watching them. Something hostile and dangerous. They could treat his penance as an escape from punishment, but few knew how dangerous the Beast Island could be. He became vigilant and cautious there, learned to look out for threats. Despite the fact that his wife provided him with the support of such a wonderful power armor, he still knew that many creatures lived there that could kill him or worse. Therefore, he straightened up and turned his back to his companions.

„Something evil is coming here.”

Ever since she found out Angela was alive, she couldn't wait to hug her and apologize for how awful she was to her all those years she thought she was. Micah is dead. She didn't care that she had changed, after all they had all changed since then.. They had become more cautious, more thoughtful and aware of what they felt. She herself had become much more open to people raised in other cultures and values. She had met students and others from the farthest corners of Etheria , former members of the Horde, and even a person from outside her planet. She had recently even met Catra's father and his entourage , very unusual people. But all this had not prepared her for what had happened to the queen. She had always been a woman of consideration, and absolutely composed. She had never resorted to violence unless it was absolutely necessary. She was a model of elegance and good breeding, an ideal ruler, the best that Etheria could get. Although she was not interested in such matters, she perfectly understood why her brother had fallen in love with her. She had been a wonderful mother to Glimmer, whom she had raised to be

a wonderful heir to the throne. And this woman inspired fear. She was a marauder, or even worse. She could see that so much evil had befallen her. Her hand… and her wings! Who could be such a monster, To strip an angelic being of her wings! As soon as she saw Hordak , she wanted to kill him, right there. There was no justice in it, only burning hatred. It was so unlike her… She couldn't imagine what it would take for someone else to become so… Filled with rage… But no, she knew someone like that… Her life had been filled with suffering, too. Catra… Now she saw in her sister-in-law the same scars she saw on her soul.

She was silent as her sister-in-law aimed directly at Hordak's biological hand. She wasn't sure if she acted like that because she was shocked by what had happened to Angela, or maybe because she secretly wanted the woman to take revenge on the former ruler of the Horde. She hated him, although she was ashamed to admit it, because she knew it was bad, but he had done so much wrong.

Then that girl… That Tiirin tried to calm her captain down and she succeeded. And then Angela said that she was as close to her as her own daughter, and then she felt her jaw drop. She would only be more surprised if it turned out that her new husband or wife would soon arrive here. She knew that five years had passed, but... A daughter right away? Tirin said that she was some Azlanti, and claimed that she was sorry for what her people had done to Angela… Who were they? Another threat to their planet? She was starting to get a headache from all this, so she was glad for the rest that her brother had offered her, everyone needed a moment of peace. However, then Hordak mentioned some threat. She rolled her eyes and said.

„Were you scared by the campfire tales? He would think that the Great Scary Lord Hordak was afraid of ghost stories. „ She laughed and Hordak gritted his teeth angrily. But her brother gave her a reproachful look. But this little creature, named Tonado, also seemed worried, and he fluffed up his blue pink fur. Angela looked at him and looked around and said

„I don't like this place. It’s look like a battlefield, and it seems to be an abandoned area.”

She and her brother looked at her seriously and Micah said.

„Don't you remember? This is the Valley of Shattered Armor... This is where we lost and I was... I was imprisoned and sent to the Beast Island... „ he glanced sideways at Hordak and asked. Don't you remember this?

She shook her head slowly and said.

„I don't remember much... I know there was a battle, and something very terrible happened there. This place reminds me of pain and... suffering. But these are just impressions. I've never been here, and I don't remember anything that happened here.”

„Because in fact, you were never here. At the time, you were taking care of our daughter… „ He explained, and his wife narrowed her eyebrows and shrugged.

„It's not important now... I wanted to say that such places are often full of the undead, and sometimes visitors from other planes, especially fiends. I've visited the Haunted wrecks and ruins several times... Once even with Ireanis and Bina's children . „ She said, and the sorceress from outside the Empire smiled as if at pleasant memories.

"Yeah, we almost got eaten by the Ghouls back then, but Daisy… Shadow Weaver, and I chased them away," she replied. She looked at the Saihe woman in surprise. She didn't seem to be very good at unscrewing anything bigger than a mosquito. Speaking of which, she'd slapped herself on the cheek, leaving a sticky stain on it. She grimaced.

„Then it would be better to check them at night...„ said the queen and then the sorceress jumped up and clapped.

„I have an idea! Hey, Micah , remember when we were here with Daisy, that's Shadow Weaver, and the kids? It was those ruins,

you know where that girl was... You know, that transparent one...”

„You mean Heart Gift?„ Her brother asked cautiously. „ I'm not sure if that's a good idea. She wasn't... She's Light Hope and Mara's child ...”

She recognized the names. The first was an ancient AI, the second a previous She-Ra… She had heard of them from Adora, but, how could they have a child? Before she could voice her doubts, something began to fly around her, and Tirin called out.

„We met her at Castle Crypto ! She's very nice!„ was clearly delighted.

„You met her? But how on Etheria?„ Micah asked, he seemed to be very surprised by the girl's words. She didn't hear the girl's answer, however, because she started to drive away something big, but when she saw out of the corner of her eye that everyone had turned pale, she looked closely at the thing, and for a moment her heart stopped in horror. In front of her a head floated on wings made of ears.. She had large empty eyes, and a mouth full of fangs, and her skin was slimy. Before anyone could react, she saw that Hordak directed his hand at him, which transformed into a Blaster and fired a beam of energy that tore the creature into shreds, which splattered them all.

„ Oh Vargouille! Do you know that if a snake bites you, you can get sick and your head will fly away?„ Saihe said in a tone as if she was explaining a nature curiosity to children in class.

People might complain that she was absent-minded , that she couldn't always focus on what they were saying to her, and that she sometimes didn't fully understand the reality around her, but she was a war mage from Nantambu after all . She had to lead her subordinates through the dense jungle of her homeland more than once. She had a good sense of direction, and in that respect

her memory functioned quite well, so she quickly led them to the mouth of the shaft that Bina's children had blown up.

„There you go! We're all here!„ she grabbed her hips, beaming with pride.

The others, however, were looking at the entrance skeptically, she didn't understand why.

"Do you think this is a safe haven?" The king's sister seemed almost convinced.

„Yes, to be honest, I'd rather fight a whole horde of the undead. It's really fun, you throw fireballs here, meteor showers there, They try to suck your life force or crack your head open to get to your brain. Ah, the good old days!”

Casta flinched at her words. Her brother, however, was skeptical.

„These are the ruins of the First Ones. They always hide dangers. And besides... This girl... She doesn't know what happened to her Mothers„ he said, scared for some unknown reason. Itsmean, the transparent one didn't know that her parents got divorced or something like that?

„Actually, she already knows.... „ Tirin said.

Micah asked , but then they heard raucous laughter, and then a raspy voice came from the darkness.

„It's you... „ They could hear the anger in it, but also the strangely cruel joy. This time it brought back those less pleasant memories.

„ Who are you? „ the king's sister called out, and then a figure in gray, torn robes entered the small circle of light. He was tall, she couldn't tell his species, or even his gender. He had a deep hood over his head, but she could also see that he wore armor underneath, and he should have had it at his belt.

„You don't know who I am? You don't remember, we all have problems with memory, but maybe when you see my face you will remember!„ he threw off his hood and then he saw that it hid a skull covered with stretched skin. The eye sockets were empty, but a green light burned in them. Everyone seemed terrified, it was hard to say why.

„It's just Wight. Nothing terrible! There is no reason to be afraid of them. They do tear out people's throats or cut off their heads, but it's not really that scary! They only kill those they have some quarrel with anyway „ she waved her hand, because it wasn't really a big problem, Some lightning, disintegration or something... Any reasonable person wouldn't take on such common creatures, why didn't they knew that. The captain reached out and aimed her hand at him, which burned with a cold flame

„Who are you and what are you looking for here! Tell me or leave it destroyed.„ she said firmly, and then Wight laughed and said.

„You've changed, but it's still you... But you weren't here when we all died, queen. You ordered me to fight here, you threw us to be devoured by the mistress of shadows. Don't you remember? It was me, your captain of the guard, Oakarm ... We were here, me and my whole squad! While you were sitting calmly in the palace with your daughter, we were dying.„ He didn't shout, although I had the impression that he was very angry, furious even. The captain's husband played and said.

„I remember you... We fought side by side! I didn't see you die, although I suspected that you didn't survive this clash like so many. And now... Listen, it's not my wife's fault, she didn't want anyone to die. No one expected Shadow Weaver to unleash such power. We weren't prepared for it, but I tried to stop her anyway... I was the one who failed, If you must seek revenge on someone, then seek it on me „ said Micah with desperation in his voice. The undead laughed, and before the shadows began to gather. Then Wight looked at her husband, the captain, and grinned, pulling the skin on his face.

„You didn't try hard enough. If you had tried harder... We would have lived... But you survived, right? You're not like us... you didn't spend the last decades Trapped in a dark nightmare. But I feel the power has returned and now I can take my revenge on those who caused our lives to be lost... We will all do this... „ he said and then he saw Brother of Wrongdak, and he seemed to want to do something, but he aimed the gun at him, and fired. The undead landed in the darkness, And the clone said.

„I don't understand why you're still talking to someone like that.”

She agreed with him, and threw a fireball.

Chapter End Notes

I've misspelled Micah's name before. Please leave your comments and opinions.

Standing side by side with a former enemy

A moment ago He realized that he had never fully believed what he had heard about this place. Not in his heart. He had read books, and he knew a few legends, but he had never fully understood what the undead were. Even after what his sister had said . He had probably thought that they were some form of meat puppets, or Dark energy pretending to be living people. However, when he looked into the eyes of the being who had once been the Captain of the Guard, he saw the former intelligence in them… And hatred… He had not expected that any of the former members were capable of feeling such hatred for their comrades in arms. Was it hatred that had caused them to rise from the dead? Hatre Dark magic…

He knew that many members of the king's guard had died during the battle, probably most of them. A similar fate befell the entire Black Guard serving the Scorpion King, as well as his daughters, who were protected by the soldiers serving in this formation. He had no idea how many more unburied warriors, and not only them. were resting in the area. But seeing the swirling shadows and shapes, he expected that there could be many of them there... Really many... That's why he thought the Fireball that the sorceress Saihe threw was a pretty good idea. He covered his eyes, and felt the waves of heat, but they were far enough away to avoid most of the effects of the explosion. He saw that light began to radiate from his wife. A bolt of bright energy shot out of her hand , hitting one of the figures hiding in the darkness. Then more creatures began to emerge from the darkness. Most of them resembled the Captain of the guard, and their eyes glowed green. They were armed and wore armor. However, there were also figures resembling Humans, but half”naked , with long claws and teeth, staring at them with eyes full of hunger.

„Ghouls! Don't let them bite you!„ His wife shouted, Although considering how those teeth looked, he still had no intention of

letting them dig into his body. Together with his sister, they began to cast a Spell to stop those creatures. However, a few of them have already broken through to their ranks.. Tonado threw himself with his sabers, between two Wights, They cut their legs with your sabers. At that time, Hordak blocked the bite and to that Ghoul, inserting an armored arm into his mouth, And then shot him with his blaster, playing off his head, and that girl... Tirin, changed one of her hands to something that threw a corrosive substance. But then, comma from the darkness, other creatures began to emerge, like animated shadows, similar to those that Shadow Weaver could create. Silently, they moved towards them. One of them touched his sister, and then Castaspela turned pale, but did not stop casting the spell. Angela shot another projectile into the shadow, dispersing it. He noticed that his wife began to radiate with an ever greater light. So strangely the sorceress laughed, as if fighting with these creatures brought her inexpressible joy. She threw another spell, which caused a lightning to shoot out from between her fingers, which jumped from one creature to another. Then they finished the spell, and a Magic barrier was created in front of them, which stopped these creatures.

„Let's hide inside!„ Angela called. „Maybe that way they'll lose interest in us.„ She finished, and then spread her wings, and held out her hand to the matter of the undead creatures, and then there was another explosion. Then they did as she told them and disappeared into the ruins of the First Ones.

Tirin was incredibly happy, which was quite strange considering that she had just been fighting a horde of undead lurking outside. The captain said that she was like a daughter. She couldn't imagine more beautiful words. Her mother crippled her, and her father always treated her more as a nuisance than as his own child. Until now, she had been very afraid of what would happen to her when the captain regained his family... Would she forget about her and leave her alone forever? She had seen her daughter, even if only in videos, and she was the child every

parent would dream of. Beautiful, strong and healthy. A heroine who helped save not only her planet but the entire galaxy... And she was crippled and unable to live independently without this suit. Now the captain said that she was like a daughter to her too, and that made her happier than anything else in the world.

Of course, it would be nice to survive too, to be able to enjoy it. There had to be hope, they all had to, that the barrier would hold long enough for them to find shelter She didn't quite understand why everyone except Ireanis and Tonado seemed to fear this place, but maybe it was because she felt more comfortable here than she did outside, and that was even before the undead showed up At first, when she arrived here, she felt scared because she found herself in an open space again, which she hated,, so she was glad that they were going to the ancient ruins. It was cramped here, on the walls she saw fragments of strange but quite nice drawings. Yes, it was quite cozy, and on top of that They will meet Heart Gift soon . She liked her. She was an artificial intelligence, but it didn't bother her. She met a few androids, Chart even served on the ship, And AIthat was almost the same. You couldn't hug her, of course, but she was also hard to hug, so it didn't matter! And why did she even think about hugging that girl?!

Micah led them, with Captain Moonshadow walking next to him and herself close behind with Tonado.. After a few moments, the sorcerer looked at her and asked.

„How do you know Heart Gift ? „ he smiled, probably not wanting her to get the impression he was questioning her. She hesitated before answering.

„ I found, or rather we found her in the undergrounds of that castle... Castle Crypto ! She was there and she was crying... We all felt very sorry for her. She was very upset, and said some unpleasant things to this woman with purple hair, to Entrapta ... „ she said, and then Hordak, who was walking at the end, covering them from behind, asked.

„ What did she tell my wife…?„ She heard the irritation in your voice, and she lowered her head in shame,

„Sorry, I forgot she's your wife. Heart Gift answered her about what happened to her parents. She was sincere, but very... unpleasant in what she said, and then Taka machine woke up, but it's nothing special... „ She tried to sound like it was nothing important, although she wasn't as good at hiding the truth as Eti... „ and then we somehow made up.

"So Castle Crypto is the ruins of the First Ones? That explains a lot... But does that mean you were with Lonnie? And her rebels? You joined to them?" Micah looked at his wife uncertainly. She considered before answering.

„It's not that simple. I joined the rebellion , but I guess for the same reason you were willing to work with that woman. With Shadow Weaver. They were the only people I could cooperate with, and besides, they had Tirin."

„They caught me, but it was completely by accident. They released me later„ she interrupted the conversation to clarify some details

"We came to an understanding and made an alliance. I offered them a sword... Adora's shattered sword... I'm not sure what they would want it for..." Captain Monshadow added carefully.

"This is truly a magnificent trophy, one of the most valuable things we have ever stolen!" Tonado exclaimed.

„But, where did you get that sword?„ The captain's husband asked in surprise. She wasn't sure, but she had the impression that the captain was blushing with embarrassment under her mask.

„I robbed my daughter... I got into the museum because I needed the sword. I thought it belonged to me. I said that my memory wasn't complete. I remembered very little, although I remember more and more. However, some of my memories were changed... Doctor Sidonius... He changed my memory. He's a very old

vampire. Really old, he remembers the times of the lost Golarion. The Azlanti hired him to help interrogate me. He probably implanted these memories in me so that I would come here, and help him get the sword, because he thought he needed it. He helped me free myself. I don't deny that I wouldn't have succeeded without his help, but he had his own interests in this... He probably believed that I would lead him to the sword and our Planet... „ She clenched her fists angrily.

„He also financed our expedition, he bought us this ship.. I think he also sent your other Eti here... „ said the elven sorceress, still smiling. She saw Micah stop in his tracks.

"So, that's how she ended up here? But why did he send her here? After all, she was a child, Adora told me about it when they met...She was a toddler in Cardboard." He said in shock

„And because he was testing some teleportation device or something like that, I don't really know because I've never talked to him, I don't like the undead... unless they're burning. Now I want to go back and fuck around some more. I've got a few more spells strong enough to raise hell there...„ she turned around, obviously thinking about it seriously

„Well, that's what you'd expect from him. Unfortunately, the son of a bitch is on Etheria , but I don't know what he's looking for or what he's planning, but I hope we'll meet again and I'll have a chance to talk to him.„ said the captain.

„ I met a vampire in Mystacor. He'd been waiting there for ages, guarding some artifact, but he was woken up first by some burglars, and then by us. Me, Catra, and Nightgale, I mean... You know, that tall Sorceress who was my assistant at the wedding... Ow!" Castaspella shouted as Ireeanis pinched her cheek. "What was that for?"

"I wanted to check if you had changed into a vampire. You here probably wouldn't even be able to tell.„ explained the sorceress with silver hair.

„How can you change? Is it some kind of contagious disease?„ Micah's sister looked at Ireanis with pure horror.

„ Well, yes, though it has to suck all your blood first. It's similar with Ghouls, but here, bite enough, and you can actually get something that turns into a Ghoul. Right, Captain?„ she looked at Moonshadow, who nodded and added.

„There are medications for that, but in the past, entire villages were depopulated this way."

„And in addition, touch of those shadows can steal your own shadow, and then you yourself will turn into a shadow... „ said finally the elven sorceress, and then Castaspella began to stare at her legs, as if searching if her shadow was still there. However, she had one more very important thing to say. She slowed down a bit, so that she found herself next to Hordak.

„Mister. Hordak … I think I need to tell you something. You see, it's Nightgale that Castaspella told me about, she has something in common with you.

The clone snorted and said

"What, apart from the fact that she's tall..."

The captain shot him a warning look, but she continued.

„ You see, she's just as tall as you... „ she said, and then Hordak stumbled , and the others looked at her with curiosity.

„What do you mean?„ asked Micah.

She was about to answer when someone started running towards them from the corridor. Everyone was focused on her, so no one had time to react and the figure ran into her, knocking her over.

„I'm sorry, but I can't move well yet.„ The person said, pinning her to the floor. The voice seemed familiar, but she was sure where she knew it from. Everyone around them aimed their

weapons or prepared spells aimed at her. However, the newcomer probably didn't notice, because she slowly and unhurriedly began to stand up. So she lifted her head and looked at the one who knocked her down, at the same time coming to the conclusion that for the second time she had collided with someone she didn't know, although at least this time she didn't lose consciousness.

She saw that the person was an android , dressed in a dress, the same color as her skin. She stood slightly swaying on her feet, as if she couldn't find her balance, but she was also smiling at them. It was only after a moment that she recognized who she was.

„Heart Gift! You look more... physical?„ she said getting up herself.

"Hi! You are Tiriin!?" the girl called out, smiling. At that moment Micah signaled the others to lower their weapons.

„Hello Heart Gift... It's nice to see you, but... Last time we saw each other, you had... You didn't have a body!” said Micah sincerely surprised, and the android nodded and explained

„Yes, because until recently I wasn't sure how to do it, and I think I wasn't allowed to. But no one can forbid me, there's no one here who could forbid me anything.„ she said and for a moment she seemed very sad, but then she smiled again. „ Eti said that some people would be happy if I had a real Body, because I'm a pretty girl, I just had to find a place that has a Manufactory capable of creating such a body. I didn't want to be an ordinary robot, but the archive mentioned a new bioroid project, and I decided to become someone like that. I chose this place because… it wouldn't be very good to show myself in the castle, and someone had already visited me here. And besides, it seems like a good area where you could practice… being” She tried to do a pirouette, and then fell over, and laughed.

“Well, I wouldn't say this area is good for practicing anything right now...„ said Castaspella .

“No, it's a great place to test mass destruction spells, and your resistance to necrotic diseases.„ The elven sorceress said. The captain nodded, then spoke to the android.

„Do you know how to get out of here?”

Heart Gift blinked twice, then pointed to come behind them.

„The easiest way is to enter through the main entrance.„ she narrowed her eyes and then added. „ The passage is not collapsed or blocked in any way... Has something happened outside?

"Yes, we are under attack. By an enemy that... Well, I'm not sure if you've ever heard of such a thing, but there is no way to negotiate with them, we are not strong enough to fight them. So please show us another way out." Moonshadow said. Heart Gift thought over her speech and replied.

“Actually, you don't have permissions, and I can't... But now I decide who has permissions and who doesn't, right? „ she looked at the others with a bit of surprise in her eyes. Micah smiled at her and said.

„It's true, there is no one above you. You are your own lady and it is only up to you what you decide to do.”

Heart Gift nodded and said.

„Come with me. Just don't make too much noise and follow me closely. There are guards there, but I'm not sure I could control them. At least not after I woke them up. I can't operate all the functions of the planetary interface yet, and besides, the inquisitor could have influenced their behavior.„ she looked at them expectantly. She grimaced, remembering that strange Mechanical creature that almost killed them all. The captain must have noticed something, because she looked at her and began to say what, but her husband asked Heart Gift .

„Inquisitor? What does that mean?”

Before the android could say anything, they heard a loud bang and then a strange, soul”piercing wail.

„Aha, so the barrier is down. So we're going to fight after all!„ Ireanis exclaimed with absolute joy.

She couldn't believe that she found herself in a reality like from the scary stories told around the campfire. *I am the Head sorcerer of Mystacor! I I'm not made for fighting, only for governing and teaching the youth! I can't fight the living dead, ghosts and worse! Why couldn't it finally be calm and normal?* She rubbed her forehead all sweaty, although she was cold. She looked at the silver-haired sorcerer, who seemed to be enjoying all this. What's worse, she seemed to be much more aware of the situation than she was. This made her feel even more helpless than before. It all felt like a very bad dream, from which she couldn't wake up. And she had to experience all this with Hordak, who unfortunately was much more competent in this situation than she was, and probably also felt good when Fighting.

She didn't like ruins either. Buildings weren't abandoned for someone to study them, or at least not for someone like her. She hadn't even prepared proper clothing, and she stumbled in a robe that was too long. It was good that she had taken warm long johns, though. When they were climbing the wide but also high stairs, she stumbled a little and would have fallen, but Hordak caught her with something and held her from falling.

„Leave me alone!„ she cried, tearing herself away from his grip.

„I wanted to help you because you would have fallen!„ he growled with irritation.

„Why would you do that?„ she said suspiciously.

„Because if something happened to you, the others would think I was guilty, just because I'm close to you. I'd rather lose my hand myself than let Catra have the satisfaction of proving to everyone

once again that I'm not trustworthy... Because you probably won't believe that I've changed, apart from the fact that I'm grateful to your brother for defending me."

She wanted to say that of course she wouldn't believe it, but she hesitated, because she had the feeling that the former ruler of the Horde expected such an answer from her, just as she expected him to betray them. It was hard to say why, but she felt bad about it.

„Lovebirds, it's great that you like each other and want to go on a date, but now is not the time, we just have to run away quickly, because remember, bites, diseases, changing into monsters.„ the sorceress called as she passed them, winked at them, cast some spell behind her, and then ran away. They looked at her for a moment, not sure how to react, and then Hordak said.

"I think she often says absurd and senseless things, so it would be better if we learned to ignore them."

She stated that she completely agreed with him on this point.

At last they came to a great hall with a high column in the center. The walls bristled with a bright light, along with grooves and inscriptions in that mysterious language of the first. The floor was covered with numerous perpendicular holes, with a match wide and two long, which led to the abyss. In fact, the path running through the center of the room was a bridge, leading to a raised platform located in the center around the column. Behind it, on the opposite wall, were gates, Unfortunately, they were closed.

„There's an exit there. Unfortunately, I can't activate it because it seems to have been damaged, unless I somehow manage to bypass the security systems, but I'm not sure how. Just in case, it was designed so that the AI can't bypass them. If it detects anything, it will activate the guards, and the same will happen if you make noise.„ Heart Gift said .

„Well, I must be careful.„ Tirin said, looking at herself in her heavy Boots.”

„Don't worry, they're not very scary. Just a little.„ the strange Girl, patted the navigator hard on the back, so that she almost fell over. She wasn't sure what Heart Gift was. She had navy blue hair, and Azure skin, and her eyes were uniformly green. Well, maybe a dress, but I don't think she had much. Besides, not even shoes. She was probably Tirin's age, although it was hard to tell how old the girl was in this strange suit. The presence of the descendant of artificial intelligence and the previous She-Ra worried her, although she wasn't sure why. Maybe because she had heard what one of her mother was planning to do. Did this person also want to do something similar to them... to them and all the inhabitants of Etheria?

Her brother nodded, and gave a sign, and they followed him out. Next to him walked the queen, suspiciously looking at the symbol on the wall, did she recognize it? Did she say anything? Supposedly she had gathered a great deal of knowledge about the culture of the first, after all she was one of the longest-living people on the planet. Unfortunately, most of her knowledge was lost with her, as she did not keep journals in a language known to the rest of the planet's inhabitants. Supposedly, Glimmer had seen similar writings on Eridania, where it was used by the local priests, but from what she knew her niece had never been eager to look through her mother's notes. Oh well, now that it turned out the queen was alive... I guess it wouldn't be necessary?

Behind her walked both girls and small furry creature, then she and the silverhaired Sorceress, and finally Hordak. The bridge they were walking on was quite wide, so she shouldn't be afraid of falling. Besides, she was the chief sorcerer of Mystacor , which was a flying island after all! She shouldn't be afraid of heights, right? But the abysses stretching out on the sides filled her with an inexplicable fear. It was different with the scatterbrained Saihe, who leaned over one of the precipices, and began to lose her balance, and only thanks to Hordak catching her, she avoided falling in a darkness.

„You're lucky I'm Entrapta's husband, and I'm used to protecting someone who pays no attention to his own safety.

The silver-haired girl looked at him in surprise.

„Entrapta? Strange name...„ she said, scratching her head.

„She has long purple hair that she can manipulate, she talks a lot mainly about technology, apparently she is Castle Crypto , don't you remember her?„ asked her the former ruler of the Horde, and Ireanis began to think for a moment, until she finally said.

„I think I met someone like that, but I was sure it was a cleaning lady or someone like that, because she was always getting into all those ventilation shafts or whatever you call it.”

Hordak looked at her for a moment, unsure of what to say, then sighed.

„If I hadn't seen my wife forget that she has a child, I would have thought that you were trying to deceive me with the fact that Entrapta is at the rebel headquarters.„ he said with resignation.

It was then that they began to approach the column, and Hear Gift said.

„This is one of the IT nodes that allowed us to manage this part of the infrastructure. I will try to hack it, but if I fail, you must be ready...„ she did not have time to finish because then another flying head flew inside. At this sight, she jumped forward with a scream and stumbled, almost falling out of the abyss, but then Hordak grabbed her and, holding her by the lapels of his robes, dragged her to the center of the room. In the meantime, Ireanis cast spell, thanks to which a small Fire projectile shot out of her hand, setting the creature on fire, which began to hit the walls, scattering pieces of burning meat, until Angela finally threw it off with a projectile from her hand. There was silence for a moment, and then they heard scratching sounds coming from the abyss on the sides. Creatures similar to whirligigs, with very long jaws resembling razors, began to climb onto the bridge. Worse still, the

sound of undead footsteps began to come from the hallway behind them, appearing at the entrance. They all pushed her back, as if they knew she wouldn't be much use in a fight, so she curled up next to Heart Gift , and watched as the others fought for their lives.

Well, he didn't hide the fact that fighting was something he was born to do, very literally. For this reason, he felt quite good at the moment, facing countless enemies. And the fact that these were mindless and monstrous opponents, whose destruction no one would blame him for, only encouraged him to fight. Creatures with long claws and teeth jumped for him, but he put on a helmet, and then no part of his body was exposed to bites. He trampled mechanical insects with his feet, and other opponents were struck down with shots from his blaster. He smiled under his msk. Maybe in this way he would gain at least a little respect from his companions, and also get closer to making amends for his actions. The others also joined the fight. The girl in this strange armor transformed the armor of her arms into two long whips, with which she struck the nearest creatures and machines, and Micah threw a stream of flame along destroying both machines and living dead, an idiotic oxymoron! This Tonado, despite his size, bravely attacked the enemies, cutting off their limbs with his sabers. The Queen threw a projectile that pushed one of these Ghouls into the abyss, along with the machine that held him, because the opponents began to fight among themselves, which was not really strange, after all, the bots of the First Ones were supposed to guard the complex from all intruders, including these dead creatures

Unfortunately, more and more enemies were coming, more Vargouils flew in , trying to bite them, and although he wasn't sure how much he could trust the word of this absurd Sorceress, he was certain that a bite from such a creature couldn't end well. He and Angela somehow managed to deal with them, systematically shooting them off when they got too close, but then the shadows arrived. To his surprise, and also the horror of

the robots, nor the blows of his armored fists were able to harm them , in fact they passed through them. He saw that one of the shadows touched the girl in the unusual armored suit, and she staggered, as if she had lost her strength. If Shadow Weaver was able to control such creatures all the time, then she must have been able to remove it during her reign in the Fright Zone... It wasn't a pleasant thought. Seeing this, the queen pressed a projectile that incinerated the shadow, then she raised her hand and screamed.

"Look away!„ And then a bright light flashed. and some of them that were closest to them were scattered, and the rest ran away. It took a few seconds for him to regain his vision, so, like the others, he retreated to the Middle platform, so now it was mostly those dead creatures and machines fighting among themselves, they had some time to breathe.

"I can't hack it, it says I lost my permissions as a rogue AI!" Heart Gift exclaimed . This girl didn't make him as anxious as she did to Micah and his sister, but she did bring back strange memories, knowledge he had gained through conditioning... Very disturbing knowledge, considering their situation.

„Keep trying, we have time, at least a little while longer, while those machines are busy with the undead. „ Micah said. But just as he finished, they heard heavy footsteps and a large dark shape began to approach them. It pressed through the door, and When they saw it, the silver"haired sorceress turned pale, and cried out.

It's Vanyvar ! Nightwing! Let's get the fuck out! „ the woman who hadn't shown any signs so far looked terrified, which meant they were in trouble.

"You better hurry up or we're all going to die." He growled irritably, and then Heart Gift called out.

„ I think I've removed the lock, but I've also turned off the power to the gate, it won't open on its own again. „ she sounded like she wanted to apologize to them.

„Maybe that's enough, try to give me some time, and maybe I'll manage to do something.„ he said and ran to the large gate, and then braced himself, and using all the strength he had in his armor, tried to open the gate. However, it didn't bring results, no matter how hard he tried, although he had the impression that if he had focused a little more, tensed his muscles a little more, he would have managed to open it. Then Heart Gift came up to him, grabbed the gate with her fingers , and also tried to open it. To his surprise, the Gate began to give way. For a moment he began to wonder how on Etheria such a small body could contain so much strength, as was contained in his extremely advanced technological armor, but then he remembered what he knew about similar beings, and he stopped being surprised after a while they managed to open the gate enough to pass through it.

„Quick! Follow me.„ shouted the comma and turned around. He saw what this creature was, which the strange sorceress was so afraid of, and he shuddered. The creature was large, resembling an emaciated hunanoid with a black and red body, covered as if with bone armor. He had long horns and huge wings made of shadowy ribbons. He was surrounded by a swarm of bots, but he destroyed them one by one. However, the others quickly ran to the other side, and then he and Heart Gift . They quickly began to close them, but then this monster jumped at them, and he felt how the unspeakable cold began to penetrate through his body. He felt an indescribable weakness, one he had never experienced since his wife had cured him of his genetic flaw.. However, they managed to close the gate, and then he exclaimed.

„Try turning on the lock!„ These words were directed at Heart Gift , who blinked twice and said.

„Done!”

Then he pulled her away from the door and began to look around the room.

„I think I've been here before... „ He stated with surprise. You found yourself in a large room, with smooth walls covered in

paintings. They were a bit neglected, but he was still able to easily recognize the images of scorpions...

"I've heard of this place. It's the hall of triumph. Supposedly this is where every scorpion lord hung out, before Scorpia of course ." Micah said. "She chose the hall of terror, probably none of her mothers ever showed her that, and neither did Shadow Weaver."

„Shadow Weaver has never been here. Or at least, she didn't show much interest in this place.„ He turned around, and saw that the gate was completely invisible on this side. It was ironic that the Dark Sorceress had the entrance to the first complex, full of mysteries and secrets, right under her nose, but she never explored it. „She didn't like the Scorpion culture. It reminded her too much of her homeland or something. I was happy about that, because this place reminded me well... I always respected scorpions. „ he said, sinking into memories.

„ That didn't stop you from trapping most of the scorpions, though. Shortly after Scorpia's mothers died.„ Castaspella said accusingly. He bowed his head, feeling the weight of guilt sinking in again

"It was after the second uprising... I could do it, or I could be imprisoned and then most likely executed," he explained quietly. The others looked around the room for a moment, then Micah asked.

„Why were you brought here? No one outside the ruling family of the Scorpions and other important figures in the state has ever been brought here.

He smiled grimly and said.

„ This is where the Scorpion King swore allegiance to Horde Prime, in return for which I swore to give him all of Etheria.”

Artificial, Immortal and Dead

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Rehiza came to the conclusion that in her not-so-long life she had made a surprisingly large number of serious mistakes. The first was of course joining the expedition during which she had lost her sight. The second was undoubtedly accepting this mission, thanks to which she had found herself on this planet forgotten by the gods, which was also one of the most important places in the known universe only thanks to the sadistic wit of the dark powers. The third was trusting this monster in the body of a beautiful aristocrat, although the simple mercenary had seen through her almost immediately. The fourth was trying to oppose The Great Old One without the proper personnel and equipment, only with the support of a group of princesses, although each of them probably had the strength of an infantry division, so it wasn't completely idiotic. There was also trusting the Lord Admiral and ignoring the truth about him, although that was a minor mistake, because there was not much she could do about it anyway... Now she wondered if working with her new allies wasn't another...

Kane Adamson was a terrifying man. He did not resemble in the slightest the anecdotal Aristocrat from his planet who, fighting in the underground, demanded a break because it was five o'clock and he had to drink tea with a little milk. Kane didn't look like someone who ruled a planet practically devoid of a proper Army either. He was more like a mercenary commander ready to overthrow a democratically elected government for a price without even blinking with that cold eye of a murderer. She had even told him about it, and in response he had smiled and said that he hadn't commanded mercenaries for ages, and she had the impression that the statement "for ages" wasn't just a phrase. She had no idea why he had come here, leaving the world he ruled,

and she was a little afraid to ask him... Perhaps he would have answered her politely, but she had the feeling that she wouldn't like his answer. He stated, however, that he had already been there, which raised the question of how he could have ended up on a planet that had only returned to the galaxy a few years ago after spending thousands of years in a pocket dimension.. The simplest answer was that he had arrived here before the planet was cut off from the rest of the universe, which made Kane someone who was older than some gods…

His companions were little better than the archduke. When they stopped at a village that was on the way to where they were going, she felt a wave of power that hit from Brightmoon . She felt the evil radiating from it... Someone had done something terrible, performed a dark, incredibly powerful ritual that tore the very fabric of reality apart and summoned a being whose power and wickedness was beyond all imagination. She felt sick from the dark power that radiated from the capital. She vomited on the floor of the inn they were staying at, although fortunately there were not many guests in the main hall, because many of the queen's subjects were staying in Brightmoon , and the roads were empty. Arkan-tar asked her anxiously what had happened, but she did not want to talk about these matters in public, so she quickly helped clean up the mess she had made, and then went with the others to the room where they were staying. Dilayla was looking through her gear, clearly dissatisfied with its condition, Dr. Quinn was dozing off and the Archduke was leafing through a thick old book. She glanced anxiously at the title, but it turned out to be a study of elven painting from Latroxia. If she had antennae, they would have quivered with surprise. This man did not look like an art lover at all, although from the way he spoke, one could see in him someone educated and highly cultured. In a way, that made him even more disturbing.

„I suppose you want to talk about what you sensed. It is indeed an interesting disturbance in the flow of power, which does not happen very often, especially in a place where it would seem that this type of Magic should not be very common. However, when we think about it more deeply, and recall the recent events related to

the arrival of one of these younger brothers of Chaugnar Faugn, we come to the obvious conclusion that Appearances can be very deceptive. You, of course, should have learned this lesson long ago, in many different ways. What is much more interesting is what has been recalled here. To my knowledge, a takeover ritual was performed here that is practically unknown in most of the Galaxy.. I myself have only heard rumors of it, and its low popularity is related to the price that must be paid for the power it offers. There is a high probability that the person who performed it will die soon, and in an extremely unpleasant way. There is also a small chance that the Warlock survived, which means they will pose an extraordinary threat to everyone. But that is none of our business anyway.„ Kane explained and went back to reading, as if nothing unusual had happened. Well, maybe in the case of someone like that, it really wasn't anything unusual. Not wanting to go downstairs, where she would probably be ashamed of her recent weakness, she went into the living room, waiting until she could go to sleep. Tomorrow they had a long journey, so they would leave the capital, although perhaps she should go back there to oppose that evil. But it was probably too late. For some time she read a book, some surprisingly good crime story, taking place in an abandoned hotel on a lonely island. Then Arkan-tar turned on the radio, and then they heard the announcement. It said that two prisoners had escaped. Among them was Shadow Weaver herself, as well as an aristocrat from a distant world called Lady Cala, and they were accompanied by a sorceress of unknown origin, and also a horse-like monster walking around. Verthani laughed shortly and said.

„Well, I have to admit that the incoming former companions are doing quite well, although I hope they won't be in the mood for a third round.„ He laughed again, and Dilayla cursed under her breath, then said furiously.

„I'm going to inform the others, in case that blonde bitch wants to finish what she started. „ And she went downstairs to Huntara and Tung Lashor. The Orc Warrior and the Lizard Gangster had decided to accompany them, though she wasn't sure why, but in the current situation she didn't complain about the extra support,

after all, someone who could cover your back would always come in handy. She was worried that Lady Cala might seek revenge on them. The aristocrat was a deadly threat in her own right, and with the help of such a powerful sorcerer as Shadow Weaver, she was ten times more dangerous. She wasn't sure what allies she had either She already knew that there were cultists on this planet, so there were probably creatures from the darkness between the stars as well. Of course, they had the support of someone like Archduke Kane Adamson, and he was a man who certainly knew how to destroy even such a vile monster as the aristocrat from Carurrystal... But he himself gave the impression of someone just as terrifying. "I helped to murder the original inhabitants of this planet." she recalled his words. It sounded almost like a joke. But the Archduke didn't seem like someone who would tell jokes, even ones that were tasteless. She wanted to believe that it was just a metaphor, or an exaggeration, and something deep in her heart told her that in this case Kane was being completely sincere, so if that was true, then they were traveling with a monster worse than any she had ever fought. And older ones, so old and ancient that it was hard to comprehend. Perhaps then, it wasn't she who should fear the aristocrat and the dark sorceress, but they who should fear the Archduke with the cold eyes.

She woke up suddenly, having fallen asleep in an armchair while Arkan-tar was looking through the same book she had just been reading. She wasn't sure what had woken her up, but she had the feeling that something bad was coming. The scholar noticed her reaction and stood up, looking at her questioningly , and she nodded in confirmation. Kane, however, seemed unfazed, calmly studying maps of the planet, and making corrections. When he noticed that they were both worried, he said.

„It will be my friend soon, maybe you managed to sense his presence. „ he didn't even look up from the maps. „Please open the window, because he will probably want to get here this way.”

With some hesitation she did as he told her, and then a large black raven flew inside. She jumped away from him, mentally

preparing to cast a spell, and Verthani reached for his weapon. Dilayla clenched her steel fists, ready to beat her potential opponent to death. After a moment, he transformed into a tall pale man, in a black coat with a top hat on his head, and mirrored glasses on his nose. Even after changing into a human, his features had something birdlike about them. When he saw them, he bowed to them and said.

"Hello! Nice to meet you, I'm Doctor Sidonius.„ He said smiling at them with a bit of superiority, and hearing his name Dilayla tensed up, and looked at him with hostility. The man noticed this and raised an eyebrow and asked.

„Do we know each other?"

"I've heard about you, and the things you've done. Bina told me who was responsible for sending that girl here... Catra... I've heard a bit about what happened to her here. And what kind of bastard would test a teleportation device on a child!" The Warrior stepped ahead, clenching her cybernetic fists as if she was barely holding herself back from punching the guy. The Doctor looked at her coldly, then said

„From what I understand, you're a mercenary, so someone like you shouldn't make any reproaches. After all, you serve the highest bidder. From what I understand, your service for this mission was paid for by none other than Lord Admiral Antares himself, right?"

Dilayla gritted her teeth and was about to say something, but then Kane interrupted.

„You are very unfair in your judgment of our companion, and those who practice her profession. Like her, they have every right to feel disgust for people like us, although of course, compared to me, you are a noble and righteous person like a Paladin.„ his voice was as if slightly bored, and Doctor Sidonius snorted Shortly, and the mercenary said.

„I'm going to our companions, I'd rather not stay in one place with someone like him, longer than necessary. Rechiiza, Quin and Verthani will surely pass on to me everything that was agreed here, and I doubt you would take my opinion into account, as well as the opinion of their companions. - she looked at them, smiling mockingly and went downstairs.„ she looked at them, smiling mockingly and went downstairs.

„Now that we have the pleasant welcome behind us, it would be appropriate to talk about our future „ We're going back to the Singing Jungle, there are some things we need to do. I think our goals are pretty clear. We still have a way to get our memories back, and find out the plans of those who took them there. From what I know, Captain Blazebringer should be nearby, maybe he's already within our reach..„ said Kane with impatience, as he explained something very obvious.

„I apologize, but I am not sure if I heard you correctly, Archduke.„ Arkan-tar asked, adjusting his glasses. „As I understand it, you are working with this extremely mysterious captain, whose existence is generally questioned. In that case, I would like to know how you met, and what his intentions are for the planet on which we happen to find ourselves.„ Verthani's usually ingratiating voice was audible with irritation. The Archduke looked at him, raising one eyebrow, as if he was merely curious, and said.

„Captain Blazebringer has no hostile intentions towards this planet. Not long ago I would have said that its destruction would be no problem for him, but now I'm not so sure. His goal is a completely different place...„ When he finished, Doctor Sidonius spoke up.

"He wants to find Eternia and….well, solve the problem of the Firsts Ones once and for all, because I have reason to believe that their intentions towards the rest of the Galaxy are not very good. „ He looked at them all triumphantly, and Arkan-tar tilted his head back, and sighed heavily, but before he could say anything, Dr. Quin spoke up.

"I'm in," she said simply, as if what their new guest had said was a question. After a moment, seeing the surprised looks directed at her, she explained.

„I witnessed the activation of the weapon that was on this planet, and I understand that it was the work of the First Ones, right?

Kane nodded and began to speak slowly and thoughtfully.

"In fact, this entire planet was weapon. It had been initiated into use twice, a little over five years ago. The first time by a certain artificial intelligence, and the second by a deranged tyrant," and he gave them a brief history of the conflict for this planet, as well as some facts about the heart of Etheria, and She-Ra, the demigoddess who had supposedly saved most of the Galaxy. She knew some of these facts, and guessed the rest, so she hadn't learned anything particularly new, but Dr. Quin had listened to the Archduke.

„If They tried to destroy us once, what they are doing now they will do it again... I was there when that weapon was activated, in the communication center... You don't understand what it was like. We were all sure that we would die, more than that, that we would be erased from reality. So if you want to stop them, then I will help you.„ Ysoki said. The Archduke nodded thoughtfully and looked at her.

„And you, a hunter of sorcerers and monsters. You lost your eyes and antennae because of one of the machines the First Ones created, right?. You studied Secrets, the meaning of which you did not even understand, and they decided to punish you for it. Now you serve the Order Of The Eclipse, which has sworn to fight threats to the existence of the entire Galaxy, and there is no doubt that the activation of the Heart was such a threat. And I assure you, this was not their last move. Over the millennia, they have created many plans, and now they are implementing them. If you stand on my side, you will not only take revenge on those who maimed you, but you will also fulfill your duty to those you serve. Consider my words carefully. Consider my words carefully.

You do not have to decide now, wait until they reach the Singing Jungle, there you will learn everything.„ said the aristocrat with the eyes of a murderer, and she thought for a moment before answering him.

"I agree now. Truth be told, I don't think I have any reason to go back to the order anyway, if I haven't noticed that I'm traveling with a monster and a dark sorcerer. Besides, I don't want to work with someone like the Lord Admiral. So since I have nothing to do with myself, I choose Revenge. It's always a good choice," she said, but then Verthani shook his head and said

„I'm just a scholar and researcher... A treasure hunter, or maybe more accurately a grave robber. „ he laughed and added. „It's not for me, all these ancient mysteries and secrets.... It's not for me, I'm not much use here anyway, so as far as I'm concerned, I'm leaving and taking no part in this endeavor.„ he said, staring at his feet, and laughed nervously.

„Maybe you should think it over, because we don't know everything yet. Come with us to the Singing Jungle, like Archduke said, and maybe then you'll change your mind.„ She said before she could bite her tongue. Why did she persuade him to do anything? If Arkan-tar wants to abandon them, it's his business, she shouldn't stand in his way! The scholar looked at her a bit surprised, smiled, which made her even angrier, and then said.

” Okay, I'll go there with you because I have no plans for the future anyway, and I'm sure they have good drinks there, and some place where you can lie in the sun... or rather the moonlight... sometimes that place is really strange.”

She felt a sense of relief that made her grit her teeth angrily, and then Dr. Sidonius pulled himself closer and said.

„That nervous mercenary is probably going too... well, it's my turn, I have to find some Shelter Before the dawn, because unfortunately I left Brightmoon in a hurry, and I had to leave my shelter... so I have to be careful, luckily I have a spare coffin in

the capital of these local Lashunti . „ he said and changed into a Raven, And then flew outside.

„Did I understand what he said correctly? He's... a vampire?„ she said in disbelief.

„Apparently. At least he's educated... As for me, I have to go to bed. We're probably getting up in the morning, and I'm tired, because out of all of you, I work the hardest, and with the most important part of my body, the Brain.„ Dr. Quin said , and then Kane added.

„ I've always found being a vampire limiting. Well, technological advances and changing lifestyles have allowed for the disadvantages of a vampire existence to be limited, but I still think there are better ways to test eternity. „ and he went back to studying the map.

She felt a little too old for this kind of thing. Extraordinary people, from distant worlds. Terrifying statues worshipped by some fucked up Bandits who wanted to sacrifice people. A man who looked like he was the son of death itself was working with them, searching for some Great Ancient Secret. Shadow Weaver had returned and brought Catra's sister with her, and as it turned out, the father of both girls had flown in with warfleet, although from what she had noticed, he wasn't very well-liked by her current companions. A quite pretty girl who had transformed into a monster before her eyes, still quite attractive. But the strangest thing of all was that Tung Lashor turned out to be hiding a big secret, and what was worse, he wasn't talking as absurdly as he used to, or maybe now what he was saying simply sounded more sensible, because she understood more. Either way, the world was changing faster and faster, and it was harder for her old legs to keep up with everything.

She stopped at a shelter on the outskirts of the village where they decided to spend some time before continuing on their journey.

She took three of her subordinates with her, two brothers, from a people who called themselves the fearful. They were called the Strag brothers , and after their last, very painful encounter with Bina's red-haired ward, they had decided to stop sniffing the underground fumes, so she decided they would accompany her. She also took a scorpion named Shelly, who had deserted the Horde along with her. He disliked Scorpia, and her entire family, for betraying his people. He was a strong and incredibly loyal warrior, and she had a feeling that loyalty would be incredibly important to her now. Tung Lashor had only taken with him the Kablod, who looked at everything with great reserve, and the Great Lizard, even stupider than his commander, which was an astonishing feat. Goldeneyes had also come with her, who, when he folded his legs, hardly looked grotesque. He walked around the shelter, looking around with interest, as if there was something interesting here. There was only the floor with a few sleeping mats spread out, although she had to admit that it was warm and quite cozy. At least she would have a place to stretch her old, aching bones... The biggest question, however, was why she was here in the first place. She wasn't sure why she had set off on this adventure, but she had a feeling that the answer was as simple as it was sad. She didn't have many adventures left to experience, so maybe she would go on the last, the biggest, most amazing! And something told her that they were also with strange people, she would certainly have a lot of unusual experiences waiting for her.

"Hey, what's up?" the big woman with light blue hair called from the doorway.

„We're making a plan for Shadow Weaver's Revenge!„ Tung Lashor shouted.

„We're resting for tomorrow, some of you don't have as much energy as you kid.„ She said smiling at the newcomer, she motioned for her to sit next to her. The woman smiled back and sat down next to her.

„Quite nice here on Etheria. I've only been tried to be killed once in a week, which, believe me, proves that this is a pretty safe

place.”

„It wasn't like this until recently, but I guess you already know about that, send it. I just hope it doesn't get worse.„ she said gloomily. The mercenary made a worried face, then said.

„Well, I won't lie to you, because you seem too smart for soothing talk. Your world has returned to the Galaxy, and now it has to deal with the problems that the entire universe is experiencing. I am a mercenary, and I have seen many dark sides of the universe. I have seen dictators, dark sorcerers, priests devoted to evil deities, and the machinations of greedy corporations. „ she added this last in a slightly quieter voice, looking at Tung Lashora . She frowned , and asked in a hushed voice as well.

„So he also worked for this corporation... for the Aspis consortium... What do you know about them?”

Dilayla grimaced and then said.

„I only worked for them once. I guarded a small port on a planet forgotten by devils and demons. At first I thought it was a good job, even if it was quite boring. They paid well, and I didn't really do anything. But something was bothering me. What was this port for, and what were we guarding here? And once a few other mercenaries came, but they looked like thugs from a dark star. It's a phraseological connection meaning really nasty bandits... They came, and started drinking by the fire. They ignored us as if we were night watchmen. Only then did I notice that they seemed to have returned from the battlefield, that they were celebrating a victory. I didn't know what they were doing there, but when one of them fell asleep I looked into his package, because he was drunk as hell, and I found a lot of jewelry there, including a medallion with picturest depicted a couple in love and then I found another similar medallion and I figured he must have stolen, Then I found out that a group of gem hunters had settled on this planet. According to the galactic law, if they lived there for ten years, the land they settled on would be theirs. But the consortium had its own plans, and they had to get rid of them. I

had no evidence to accuse anyone, I didn't even know the identity of these mercenaries, and besides, I didn't want to risk a conflict with one of the most powerful companies in the galaxy.„ The woman with blue hair said gloomily, and then she took out her bags and a large bottle of Brightmoon wine, and took a long sip from the bottle. She looked at it carefully, then closed her eyes and said.

„It's just wonderful. This is what we still lacked... I hope they won't find out about our planet anytime soon.„ she said and rubbed her face with her hands. The mercenary patted her on the back and said.

"You'll deal with these bastards without a problem. You are a warlike people, I mean the inhabitants of Etheria, although your species is famous for its warlike nature... Or at least they used to be ... because now...„ she pondered.

"What do you mean they were like that?" She didn't know much about her people, she was too young to remember everything when the Horde came, and on top of that, her peoplee had already forgotten a lot by then. She remembered that short redhead girl who had told her she was an orc. She had never heard that name before, and it seemed like something universally common . Dilayla sighed heavily, and then spoke thoughtfully, as if trying to remember what she knew.

„In ancient times, orcs are said to have been one of the most feared Species.. Supposedly they come from the lost Golarion, where humans or elves also come from, and I am a Half-Blood Elf, or as you call them here Saihe ... although it is more complicated... Returning to orcs, your ancestors were Warlike, to the point that they were considered to have war in their blood... I know little about them, to tell the truth, but I know who I will face. The drow enslaved them, made them their own army and servants. The drow are elves tainted with demonic essence, often, but not always, with hearts plagued by darkness. They live, for on a planet called Apostate... It's a very mysterious place, apparently the entire planet is a huge armory left by an older and mysterious

Civilization... Damn, It's a bit like what they said about this place... Your compatriots finally gained partial freedom, at least some of them, but most still serve their masters, only sometimes they get paid for it. They... They are often trained from childhood to serve their Masters. They are conditioned to be perfect servants and soldiers, even those who are not slaves. In a way, they are like those Unfortunate clones, but their enslavement concerns even their souls...„ the mercenary finished and a gloomy silence fell.

She drank after listening to the woman's words. The words didn't hurt her immediately, but she felt that they were settling the fire in her heart. She had sacrificed much to free herself from the tyranny of the Horde, and she considered its fall one of the greatest events of her life, and now she realized that it actually meant nothing. Others could boast that they had defeated a mad galactic tyrant, and freed the universe, or at least a significant part of it, from his rule. Now, however, she learned that her people were Enslaved, and no one was going to free them. It was too new and shocking news for her to feel a burning Anger, but she could see that she would soon begin to feel rage. Only, it was more of an empty, pointless rage, at beings she had never even met. She had never even left her planet, she couldn't even imagine the vastness of the universe. Even that fool Tung Lashor understood the Universe they lived in better than she, who had always perceived herself as someone who saw everything that was needed in life. Now it turned out that she didn't know anything ... She didn't even know the history of her people, or even her language. She rubbed her forehead, and understood that this expedition would not be just in search of new adventures. Perhaps it would be the beginning of something bigger, the beginning of her own history. She might have been a legend of the Crimson Wastes, but she understood that now she should become something more...

In the morning they set off on their journey towards the Singing Jungle. Whatever he said, the name sounded quite promising.

Even if he didn't feel like continuing this expedition, he might find some work there, and rest for a while after all this. He reckoned with the fact that in his life he would meet the undead, he might become a victim of ancient curses, he might be killed by cunningly designed traps. He didn't mind it. He liked even participating in the local political games, in a way it was quite funny. But participating in the intrigues of immortals? Conspiracies on a galactic scale? Monsters, both literal and those in mortal bodies, hunting for his life, was definitely too much. He knew that abandoning this expedition was the right thing to do. So why did he feel guilty? He had worked for Doktor Sidonius from the beginning, so there was no need to say that he had ever been loyal to Antares , or anyone else. He had always served himself first and foremost, and worked for those who could provide him with a comfortable and somewhat interesting life. That hadn't changed, but... something had changed. He had brushed against death, and not once, in recent months, but that wasn't the point. It wasn't the fact that his life was in danger that made him start looking at his life differently. That had happened to him before. This time, however, he looked into the eyes of true evil. And many times. He saw it in the cold and amused eyes of Lady Cala, in the cool gaze of the Lord Admiral, in the somewhat cruel gaze of Lady Ka, and even in the stony eyes of Horde Prime. He understood that the world was no longer just a joke, a big joke that you could laugh at while sipping a glass of wine. His choices mattered, and not just to him but to everyone around him. He began to participate in a game, the outcome of which could decide the fate of millions, maybe even billions of beings. That's why he knew he couldn't just abandon this mission, though on the other hand he wasn't sure if working with someone like Archduke Kane was the best idea.

There was another reason he didn't want to leave these people. For the first time in his life, he began to feel something that could be called friendship. For both the tough mercenary and the conceid doctor, he felt something more than simple sympathy. And as for Rechiiza ... He wasn't sure what he felt for her. This woman had seemed cold and closed in on herself from the beginning.

There was bitterness in her, although between gods and truth, most of his traveling companions hid sadness and unhealed wounds... She was strong, and stuck to her ideals, while he... Well, he only thought about his own pleasure and the money he would earn after this expedition. Both of them, through their loyalty, allowed evil to triumph. But she knew that she had to make amends for what her silence had led to. All of them, except perhaps Dilayla, ignored the obvious signals, although even the mercenary did nothing to oppose Lady Cala and Shadow Weaver. However, the pervert had a strength in her that made her ready for her mistakes. And there was something about her that made her want to see him as more than just a learned sly one, a treasure hunter who only wanted riches and applause. But why was this woman's opinion so important to him? He didn't want to think about it. Because the conclusion... Well, it wasn't something bad. But... a relationship with someone like him was unthinkable, for so many years he had always been alone, only having short affairs with people of both sexes. But a longer relationship? This was something new and unknown. Something terrifying.

They were approaching the capital of the singing jungle, a place that must have been rebuilt after the war, because the mad tyrant had almost completely destroyed it. It was called Eternalsong , and it was surprisingly Picturesque, and most of its inhabitants were the strange Winged Lashunta. The sight of them made Rechiza lower her eyes glumly, then pull her hood up.

It turned out that this time an official welcome awaited them. Princess Sweet Bee's Seneschal was waiting for them in formal attire, a robe of transparent silk arranged in many multi-colored layers that interpenetrated each other. He wore a wreath of flowers on his head that looked as if they were made of crystal, and then he led them to a small palace, which in this place, where most of the buildings had been destroyed by the war, was quite a luxury. It was evening, and the darker moons were shining outside the window. The four of them, the archduke and the doctor, as well as Huntara and Tung Lashor were invited to the grand salon. Inside, the two remaining members of Archduke Kane's retinue were waiting for them . One was a tall, fair-skinned

girl with almond eyes and light brown hair. She was quite pretty, though she had a strange Aura about her. The other was an automaton from the Lost Golarion, a truly extraordinary sight, though he was probably the only one who could appreciate its uniqueness.

„This is my daughter Sari... „ said Doctor Sidonius. The girl smiled, a little wider than she had to, revealing clearly too long fangs. There was nothing different about the vampire's daughter being a Dhampir , but she was also half-elf . He had heard that her mother had died in some experiment with a teleportation device , and now a few facts fell into place. The girl offered him her hand, which he kissed, making Dilayla roll her eyes, and Rechiza gave him a piercing look from her metal eyes.

„Oh how good to meet you, is it true that you traveled with Eti?„ the Vampire's Daughter asked directly.

„Yes, we were together on the same ship for a while, although we weren't very close. She was a very reserved girl, and it was only here that I found out she was related to Kim.„ he replied, smiling friendly, and then Sari added.

„She's a very nice person, if you only get to know her, and we got to know each other quite well... „ She winked significantly, and he immediately felt Rechiza calm down. Well , he wasn't going to hit on her anyway.

„And I'm Prince Zed. Please sit down.„ He pointed to the chairs. Everyone sat down, although Lashor had some trouble because of his tail. When quite a few of them were left alone, Prince Zed turned to Dilayla in an apologetic tone .

„I'm sorry for everything that happened to your planet.”

„It's probably not your fault, you don't look like one of the clones, and besides, even they weren't entirely to blame.”

A sad smile appeared on the artificial automaton's face and he said.

„Unfortunately, I am responsible for all of this, if only indirectly. I am the created son-clone of Horde Prime ...”

When he said this, all, the mercenary , the lizard, and the orc warrior jumped to their feet and reached for their weapons, as did the archduke, though Rather he wanted to defend the automaton.

„I understand your reaction, since my father was not a person… Well he was a deranged psychopath responsible for the deaths of billions of lives, so it is understandable that you suspect that I may be a person of a similar nature. Fortunately, you need not worry, since I have little in common with my father.„ Zed explained, trying to sound reassuring. Unexpectedly, the witchwarper supported him, stating.

„What I've heard about him is that for a thousand years, and certainly since the Gap, he's been a local tourist attraction, nothing more. Perhaps he harbors a dark spirit in that artificial body, but I have no reason to suspect that.:

Automaton Bowed to Lashunti in thanks, then said.

„Thank you for your support, I am very proud that my Duchy can boast such a monument as me! You can't even imagine how much they earned thanks to people who wanted to talk to me. However, I am lying to them a bit, because only a part of my story, and a relatively small one at that, concerns ancient Golarion. Moreover, technically I am not an automaton, although one of them once lent me his body, for which I am extremely grateful. My Lord, the so-called father, because I would have created me as one of his many simulacra , was also born on the lost Golarion. However, due to his mistakes and the fact that he messed with too powerful beings, he had to leave this planet. He was a master of Planar magic, thanks to which he managed to get somewhere very far away. In the dark void he met exiles from a certain planet... Ashenzee. Thanks to his power, he was able to convince them to accept him as one of their own, and by extension me. For some time they exchanged knowledge, and each other was corrupted... All were proud beyond measure, but my father and Creator was

the most powerful, and the most cunning. He quickly became their leader, and then persuaded it to return to their world. Thanks to the combined knowledge of both of them, they became powerful as Gods, At least for the inhabitants of their world... They began to worship us like gods, but unfortunately, this caused a foil. There were guardians of the galaxy, who could not tolerate something like this. A single man can claim to be God, if I work long enough, maybe he will become one, but an entire group of beings? This could not be accepted. The world was destroyed, but my father annd Creator foresaw this, so he prepared an escape route. For some time we tried to distance ourselves from that planet, but then we believed our selves in an artificial dimension. Our Creator was a master of creating artificial flowers... We waited there for eons... Contrary to appearances, not so long, because we were found by another proud and ruthless race, who desired more power and might... They awakened us and gave us new material bodies. My father-creator became their advisor and warned them against those who destroyed Ashenzee. However, they already knew them, although they initially perceived them as allies, or rather patrons, thanks to whom they managed to destroy the Bloodstones, created by the ancient civilization of the Krellans. They were crystalline computers, extremely powerful, but also hungry for the life energy of other beings, at one time they were a greater threat to the Galaxy than the Swarm is today.„ Prince Zed said, and then Kane added.

„In fact, they were dangerous, but also cunning. The First Ones, because as you can guess, we're talking about them here, they encountered one of them on their home planet, and defeated him, and then their patrons shared their knowledge with them... And they developed it. I encountered one and... I became his champion, chosen one or maybe Avatar, but when I understood that... he wanted to make me his servant... Many years later I started working with the First Ones and I think, because unfortunately due to the Gap, I don't remember everything, I became their very important scholar, mainly because of my knowledge of the Elder races... and not only. The Archduke was

finishing and then the automaton returned to continue his lecture.”

„Yes, my master became a good advisor, and he understood the first ones very well... Their arrogance, and aversion to magic practiced by ordinary people, made their cooperation work out exceptionally well. However, then the First Ones began to arouse suspicion of their former patrons. The ancient civilization living on Elder Pharos. I managed to convince everyone to create a new body for me, and some time later I managed to escape. My father-creator convinced his new allies to give him more and more power, and then through his influence he encouraged them to war against their former patrons. He counted on taking control over them, and also to take revenge on those who took Ashenzee from him. However, the first ones were not so stupid, although they got into a war that they could not win at first glance, they had many weapons, even a few. One of them was this planet... With its help, they destroyed the home world, the only world inhabited by their patrons, But unfortunately, as you have probably heard, they lost control over it, Just like over the second planet, where they were creating a project of a certain biological weapon... But They managed to create another weapon... An invincible army...they were manipulated and took terrible revenge. They cut his mind and self, burned his memory and created this pathetic creature, What does it mean as Horde Prime… They lost the war, according to their enemies, and as well as with the rebel colonies, and hid somewhere… No one knows where… But Revenge belonged to them. They destroyed the rebels, and their former patrons died out long ago, but the world was changing. It is not easy to regain former power, just like conquering the universe. You see, they wanted to cleanse the universe of intelligent life that was not of their kind… And they still want to, I assure you…” The automaton finished and the entire room fell silent. His companions knew some of the story, and the rest of what they had heard filled in on what they already knew, but Huntara and Tung Lashor … They were clearly shocked by what they heard, and there was nothing surprising about it.

"So Lady Cala and this Dark sorcerer are servants of the First Ones?" Rechiza asked, but Kane just laughed.

„Oh no... They serve much older beings, as old as the universe itself. What's more, I suspect we share common goals and common enemies, though Slightly different in the ways we seek to achieve them... Slightly...”

„But what's that to us? You're an ancient and immortal scientist, and Dr. Sidonius is an ancient vampire, and Prince Zed... I have no idea who he is... What can we do?”

Kane smiled and said.

„The future of this world has always been decided not by Immortals, Gods, and the Great Old Ones, but by ordinary mortals. You are needed and I believe that you will help us. You still have a few days to think about it, and if you change your mind, I will leave you enough money, so that you can lead a prosperous life, although it may last much shorter if we do not succeed...”

"I'd like to ask you one more thing!" Dr. Quin exclaimed, the least moved of them all by the story she had just heard. "What was Horde Prime's original name?"

„Syndara. His name was Syndara.”

Chapter End Notes

You've been waiting for this chapter for a long time. Yes, Horde Prime is Syndara from the Ruby Phoenix Tournament.

Homecoming

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She was sitting, or rather half lying on the seat of the antigravity vehicle, with her eyes closed, thinking about her Past, although some would probably suggest that she should focus on the future. However, it was clear and obvious to her. She saw what would happen to her in the next few hours, and she accepted her fate. It brought surprising relief, even though she was now returning to the place she had sworn to herself never to visit again. She was also going to meet a woman she hated with all her heart... Although, to be honest, Hate was not the right term. She spent most of her life away from her, not really thinking about her. Her mother was a stranger to her. She was like a character from a fairy tale that you were afraid of as a child. And yet still... And yet, despite herself, she still felt fear. Not that she could do something to her, but something terribly undefined. She couldn't specify these fears... Catra would probably find it as funny as it was pathetic. She, the Great and Dark sorcerer, the one who ruled the largest Empire on the planet at one time, whose wrath thousands feared, was afraid of meeting her own mother. Indeed, there was something pathetic in it. However, it must be admitted that her mother In her youth was an extremely dangerous woman, ruthlessly getting rid of enemies. Was she now one of them? Well, her family always Lived in the name of the motto, this is not with us, this is against us

Stormheart watched her warily, trying not to take her eyes off her. Because of this, her sister barely slept, and ate and drank only what was brought to her. When she went, she ordered her guards to watch her, and relieved herself as quickly as possible. It was a bit funny, but she still felt sorry for her. And she also understood her. She had reason to distrust her, because of what she had done

so far, and what she was about to do. Unfortunately, Stormheart had no right to know about the latter .

At last the captain of their craft called out that they were there. She straightened her back and went to the upper deck, and the storm keeper followed her

She saw the capital of her country, Shadepoint. At the sight, she sucked in a breath. Shadepoint was the largest port on the Isles of Sorrow, and also the most magnificent. Her Clan's fleet was stationed here, a great source of pride for her family. Every year, ships arrived here, from all the islands of this Archipelago, and once from the Scorpion Kingdom. She guessed that trade had collapsed after the outbreak of the war, but she was not prepared for what she saw.

The entire coast was covered in wrecks of ships, mostly warships made of the dark wood her nation was famous for. They had probably been lying there for years. She guessed who had sunk them, because who else could have done it? Horde Prme did not tolerate resistance, and would mete out ruthless punishment to those who opposed him. The city suffered massive damage, the entire Workers' and commercial districts were destroyed. They tried to rebuild it, but she could see it was going slowly. Most of the residents had to squeeze into containers converted into apartments , Or tents. Most of the workshops were rebuilt, however, their goods were too valuable to be forgotten. She wondered now, How much the clans had opened up to the outside world. They had the embassy in Brightmoon, and perhaps they would continue to have it, What about the other kingdoms? She knew that goods from her country, especially luxury items, had always been highly valued, so that explained where the containers had come from, and also why they had been so quick to rebuild the workshops.

However, the palaces of the great families, temples and gardens remained intact.. Even after all these years, she had to admit they were beautiful, in their own darkly majestic way. She guessed they had only survived because Horde Prime had deemed them

too beautiful to simply destroy, though she suspected the temple had been remodeled in his style, but no expense had been spared to restore it to its former state. The waterfront was still pretty much destroyed, so the fact that they had antigrav vehicles helped me a lot. She guessed that rebuilding the port was now a priority for her mother and the entire Clan, but she also knew that by sticking to the old ways, they would have no chance of rebuilding all what they had lost. That was probably why they had started playing this strange game with People's Rebellion, although it would have been much easier to simply open the border to the rest of Ettheria, and even the universe, but her people had never been guided by what was easiest. Sometimes such stubbornness was a source of pride, but not in their case. Through their pride, fear, and xenophobia, they only deepened the suffering of their subjects. But there was nothing she could do about it… Or was she?

A delegation from the palace was already waiting for them. The armor of the Clan Guard, they were not as heavy and durable as the armor of the Storm Riders, but they were much more expensive and intricately made. She did not recognize their commander, he looked like a young son of clan probably born after she had left the islands. He looked at her with a mixture of uncertainty and disgust. She wondered if he had been promoted only now, because her mother had sent the least promising officer here, in case her Prodigal daughter decided that she would not go to meet her mother. She smiled and wrapped herself in the cloak of Shadow, and sent tendrils of darkness towards the guards, so they took up arms, but immediately afterwards she withdrew them, and recalled her power.

"What are you doing?" Stormheart shouted , placing her glaive blade against her back.

„I did nothing of the sort, I only showed what a wonderful prisoner you brought back.„ she replied to her sister, smiling. She saw the fear in the eyes of the Guardsmen, as well as the disgust at the sight of her deformed face. She was pretty much used to it, throughout her time in the service… Throughout her time leading

the Horde, she had seen a similar reaction from all of her subordinates, both officers and the children she had been entrusted with. She felt a pang of remorse, because she had promised herself that she would change. But then again, these were her mother's subordinates, who was a woman just as Cruel as she was ruthless.

"Miss… Light Spinner has been ordered to appear before the First Mother Whispering Mist of the Yago Clan to answer for her sins." The captain of the guard said in a very uncertain voice. She tilted her head to the side as if watching him with interest, but didn't move from her spot.

"Did you understand what we were saying to you?" the officer said with a trace of panic in his voice. She raised her eyebrows theatrically, as if completely surprised by his words.

„Oh, you asked me, right? I think there must have been a mistake here. Light Spinner died many years ago, making a terrible mistake. The person standing before you is Shadow Weaver. What's more, from what I know, she has not committed any crimes against your ruler, so I guess I can go, right?„ she said gently, trying to sound like a true lady from Carurystal. The officer looked completely terrified, he pulled out his weapon, but immediately put it away, and pulled it out again.

„Does that mean... That you refuse to carry out the First Mother's orders?„ he said in a breaking voice.

„I didn't say anything of the sort, I just pointed out that the orders clearly didn't apply to me.„ She replied, feeling genuine amusement in her heart. She was a little sorry that Catra couldn't see her now. She would probably appreciate her display. It was different with her sister. The Storm Warden growled and said sharply.

„Could you stop this farce? The only thing you'll achieve is to make trouble for yourself, me, and Windsinger..„ She pointed to

the officer, who looked at the warrior with gratitude. She sighed and said.

„Good, this time I'll do you a favor and I'll follow you, because my sister asks me to, although in an unusual way.„ She said and let herself be led. Midnight Mask followed her right after they landed, she was silent , watching the whole conversation carefully, trying as usual to understand as much as possible, most likely as usual Interpreting everything she saw in her own way. Some people never change. She wonder if that also applied to her mother?

As they walked through the city, many of its inhabitants stole glances at her. She doubted that he recognized her, except perhaps those who had previously served in the palace or the temple, but even that was doubtful. She looked completely different now, as evidenced by the signs that some people made to ward off evil. She was surprised to find that this place was much more like the worlds beyond Etheria than any place on this planet. It might not be entirely similar to peaceful Carurystal, but she had heard of many other places in the galaxy. An Apostate planet inhabited by Drow came to mind, Dark Elves with hearts infected with demonic essence, Who supposedly once lived in the underground of the lost Golarion, and now inhabiting their own planet supported themselves by trading weapons and other suspicious goods. She had read a bit about them, and saw similarities to the culture of her nation. It was more than disturbing. Their language resembled Elven, although what she had learned, it was difficult for someone who knew the common language of the elves to understand. She knew little about linguistics, to tell the truth, this field of study was not particularly useful on this planet, where most people spoke one language. She herself had mastered only a few languages, they had only come in handy when she left Etheria... She had learned a few of them only because she had sold her soul to the darkness between the stars. She wondered now how much their family culture was similar to the culture of the inhabitants of the cursed Apostate. She should investigate her people's heritage more thoroughly, considering the

wealth of knowledge she gained upon leaving her world. Too bad she had not had time for it.

Her sisters seemed to be much more tense than she was, even though she was the one who was supposed to meet the ruthless ruler of the Isles of Sorrow. However, she was the one in control of the situation now. Stormheart could believe that she was alert enough to watch her tricks, but the Storm Warden was never cunning enough to keep up with her plans. She wasn't stupid, sometimes she wondered if in some way she was the smartest of them. But you just had to see the world and people as better than they really were.. Midnight Mask suspected something, her Dark Lord could give her some information and a warning of what would happen, although then she should have been much more terrified.

Finally they were led to the palace, a several-story structure made of darkwood, harder than most metals. She knew that some varieties of it grew on other planets, and were eagerly cultivated and used by the elves… It was one of the greatest treasures of the islands, and she wondered how much harder it was than the wood used in the rest of the universe. The windows were made of a thin material, made of spider webs, painted in various colors, so that they looked like stained glass. The roof was made of jade tiles. The entire structure had taken many generations to build, and was probably more expensive than Brightmoon Castle. Before the doors, made of black wood covered with intricately carved obsidian slabs, another group of guards met her. Stormheart wanted to go in with her but she was sent away, they only allow their Black Blade. It showed well what kind of arrangements still existed in her family. Theoretically, the Storm Wardeens were not subject to the rule of the clans, although of course her mother had a different opinion on the matter. But she liked to follow traditions and conventions when it suited her.

More guards led her through wide corridors, bathed in multi-colored light. The servants and officials got out of their way, they were well trained so that in such situations it is better not to be close to the center of events They acted very wisely, even if they

did not know what would happen. Finally, she reached the throne room of a huge room, the walls of which were decorated with blue and white bas-reliefs made of wood and lacquer, telling the history of her people and the Clan. Although her people did not possess as many technological advances as the rest of the planet, they immediately noticed that an Energy Shield ran through the center of the room, which complicated her Plans somewhat, but it was not a problem that could not be bypassed.. On the obsidian throne, carved to resemble a spider, embracing the ruler with its legs, sat an Older Woman. Her hair was already gray, and her face was gaunt and lined and scarred, clear evidence of many years of ruling with an iron fist in a world full of conspiracies and murder. Her hands were twisted from rheumatism , and perhaps from the effects of poisons, or curses, to which she had fallen victim over the years. which made them resemble the claws of one of the witches, which she had seen in illustrations in fairy tales... or when she looked in the mirror. Her fingernails were like claws, and the middle finger on each hand was several centimeters long and sharpened. The matriarch of each clan would dip it in poison to mix punishment for the disobedient, or if she wanted to defend herself against assassins… Her mother's eyes were as sharp as ever, and when she looked into them, irritation and contempt appeared in them.

"You look awful," her mother said simply angrily, clenching her fingernails on the arms of the throne.

„The same could be said about you.„ She simply said wearily. The entire throne room fell into an almost painful silence. She doubted that anyone had dared to speak to her mother like that, and certainly not since she could remember. Whispering Mist had not always been the absolute ruler of her clan, she had heard that from her teachers, she had strengthened her position through intrigue and murder. Even in her lifetime, she had had to carry out many plots to get rid of her rivals. But now she sensed that she was stronger than ever. That was good, the feeling of security would leave her vulnerable to attack.

The ruler of the Yago clan looked at her for a moment. If she had been anyone else, she would have probably been punished terribly, but she was her daughter, and for that she was needed, So Whispering Mist just snorted and ordered.

„Take her to the infidel room, I think we can consider her one of them. She will wait there for a decision on what to do with her.„ she raises her hand and the guards began to carry out her order. Midnight Mask stayed where she was, watching her with a thoughtful gaze.

You could say she was imprisoned in the guest room. In the old days, emissaries from other kingdoms were hosted here. Why was there no shortage of comfort here? There were two wide beds, windows took up the entire wall, making it unusually bright, at least for the Islands of Sorrow, where it rained constantly. It was electric light, and even a simple computer, if anyone needed to check the data they brought. The latter was clear evidence that the borders had been opened to trade, even if not very intensive. The country needed funds for reconstruction, and it could no longer afford complete isolation. The invasion of the Galactic Horde showed how great a pipe dream the desire to cut itself off from foreign influences was. Sure, if they asked, Glimmer would help me rebuild, but it would require humility, and it was difficult to find it among the members of her family, she was the best example of that. She would most willingly lie down, although she was not really tired, but she had a lot of work ahead of her. First, she discreetly cast an illusion spell , because she was aware that she was being watched and only by the guards who were waiting outside the door, but also by Midnight Mask's subordinates ... But she suspected that they weren't ready for the spells she had learned both during her studies and work in Mystacor, and her time in the Horde, not to mention what she had learned during her time on Carurystal. Here, however, she had to be careful, although didn't anyone in this palace know that one should always be vigilant and careful? Except perhaps for her, for at some point she had forgotten, as her face showed. She knelt down, moved

the carpet and began to draw a Sorcerer Circle on the floor, but after a while someone entered the room. She stood up immediately, covering the carpet, and then turned around and saw a girl with blue eyes and dark navy blue hair standing high. She was wearing the robes of a low-ranking courtier, someone not much better than a servant.

„I am Silent Scream. I will come to you as your personal servant, I have to fulfill all your orders."

She sighed at the Uneasiness in the newcomer's eyes. It was a good thing she hadn't added that she would obey "absolutely all of her commands because then She would have uttered some nasty curses at Whispering Mist. She didn't doubt that the girl would have fulfilled even those special wishes, but even in the Horde she hadn't used her power like that. She looked at her , and thought. Her name was an oxymoron, and such names were only given to the children of criminals, those born from relationships not planned by the ruler of the Clan, or those from mixed pairs. In such a case, it was still a great achievement that she was allowed to work in the palace. However, she looked closely at her face, and understood the truth. She sighed heavily, but refrained from touching her face.

„No, I don't want anything from you, child. I hope they treat you well."

Silent Scream She looked at her in surprise, but lowered her gaze and said.

„The First Matron of the Yago clan is very kind to me and accepted me despite my background. No one else would have done this for me... for someone like me... I am eternally grateful to her for that.

She bit her lip as she heard the girl's words. Silent Scream lived on a planet inhabited by some of the friendliest and most open beings, but she was trapped in its darkest corner, the only place where her origins mattered. Anywhere else they probably wouldn't

even understand how someone could despise someone because their parents weren't married, because their union wasn't approved... No one even thought about marriage in a political way. Marriage was a choice of love, and no one should stand in its way... Unless you were the second-in-command in the army of the space invader. She started laughing nervously, and Silent Scream looked at her and probably, as if a little scared... Which was logical, because now she looked a little crazy... Maybe she was a little crazy...

"Is something wrong ma'am?" she asked cautiously, obviously frightened. She shook her head before answering.

„No child, I just remembered what a certain horrible woman, just as horrible as her mother, did, and don't call me ma'am, just address me by my real name: Shadow Weaver."

Silent Scream nodded and left, apparently deciding that it was best to leave her alone. Which was good, because she had a lot of work to do.

She didn't rest for a moment, they were working hard to prepare for the reunion with her own mother. She knew that Whispering Mist wanted to soften her up before the actual conversation. Well, her own mother taught her to be tough, but what life had taught her later had made her as resilient as a diamond. She guessed what he wanted from her, and it even made sense. But of course she could only give one answer, why she had to prepare herself too. She suspected that escaping wouldn't be the slightest problem, but it wasn't escaping that she wanted. She had to follow the orders of this Star Elf, even if she hated him as hot as the heart of the sun. She couldn't afford to escape again, and at this time, not only because of will of the Creeping Chaos, but also for the sake of her daughter. That's why she had to solve a problem once and for all. She had to take back Whispering Mist's power.

She was kept in the room for many hours, maybe even a whole day, but she still finished all her plans just before the guards came You smiled at them innocently, which looked especially creepy in her current state, and followed them without saying anything. This time her mother organized an official audience, to which not only the most important courtiers came, but also the heads of all the great families, and even envoys from other clans. She recognized few, because although her people were long-lived, a lot has happened since then. She only wondered if the invasion of the mad tyrant and the resistance they put up against him were responsible for this state of affairs, or the problem-solving method practiced by the leader of the Yago Clan. Silence fell upon her as she entered, she showed no sign of humility, as was probably expected… This once, she decided to use all the immense reserves of arrogance that lay within her soul. Just this once, she would benefit from them.

"First Mother of the Yago Clan …" The Herald began to list all of her mother's titles, which should have taken a good ten minutes, but she wasn't about to let that happen.

„Everyone here knows my mother's titles, and they're probably bored to hear them again, so let's get to the point?„ she said, trying to make her voice sound as bored as possible. If Everyone had been Quiet before, now everyone was trying to quiet their own heartbeats. They had probably never heard anyone address their Ruler like that. But that was just the beginning.

„Be careful what you say! I could still take you to the dungeon, where your feet will rot from the stagnant water up to your ankles, and your body will be more gnawed by crabs while you sleep.„ said her mother after a while, her voice as cold as ice.

You would have to get in line, because currently I would be imprisoned by quite a few people, with the ruler of Etheria at the forefront. Besides, the Crabs who would want to taste my flesh would probably die in terrible agony.„ She said still showing no other emotion, except boredom. Her mother dug her claws into the arms of the chair, clearly barely containing your Rage.

"You have always been, Light Spinner , the stubborn and most disobedient of my daughters, and I see that your time among the foreigners has only warped your character. It will take some time to teach you the virtue of obedience again, but I think it will be worth the effort. I forgive you for your betrayal of your family, for I need you. The actions of the little queen have left our country in danger, and we must use every means at our disposal to protect our independence and our culture!" her mother exclaimed. She stared dispassionately for a moment, then began to laugh. This continued for some time, until Whispering Mist finally drawled.

„Apparently, you need to learn humility... A day tied to posts by the seaside facing the wind should soften you up a bit.„ She signaled the guards to all of them to deal with her, but then darkness swirled around her. She shot fleshy tentacles towards the guards, pinning them to the ground. The entire room was covered in darkness.

„I guess someone else will learn humility now... Indeed, my character has been warped, as has my body and soul, there is no doubt about that. It happened because of the choices I made, and I am primarily responsible for what happened to me. However, your teachings have shaped me. You taught me how important ambition is, how much one must do to achieve what one desires. However, do not be so proud of yourself. All my successes, and above all, all my failures I owe to myself. All the evil I have done in my life is my work.„ Her voice echoed loudly in the spacious throne room , so that the black wood resonated.

"You will pay for this! You can't even imagine how severe the punishment will be..." her mother growled, but a tentacle woven from shadows wrapped around her mouth,

„Believe me, I've done a lot of wrongs that I must pay for, but standing up to you was one of the noblest things I've done in my lousy life. I've betrayed my own planet, I hurt girls to whom I was like a mother, thousands have died in the name of my ambition and lust for power, I've sold my soul to The Darkness Between The Stars, and so much more, and in your boundless ignorance,

you're convinced that the greatest crime I've committed was breaking a few worthless traditions of our people! You don't even realize the vastness of the universe that's knocking on your door. Or should I say battering it down with a battering ram. To the true powers of the Galaxy, your small kingdom is less than nothing. They could crush it as easily as you crack a crab's shell to get to the tasty meat. I wouldn't honor you with my presence if it weren't for the fact that I have to get to a certain place, and I had to save those who are truly important to me, and you are not one of them. „ She lifted her hand and the floor opened, creating a shadowy lake. A large creature emerged from it, resembling a white-gray insect with the head of a wolf or a Jackal, and a large phytolic abdomen. Ximtal , one of the Sahkils, fiends who feed on fear. He directed his abdomen toward her mother, and a moment ago a mist enveloped her, and as it unfurled the woman began to look around in terror.

"Where did everyone go? Where did you take them?" Whispering Mist shouted, and she responded with a grim smile.

„They are in the same place where they were, just like you, but you are not able to notice each other. In fact, on the entire planet, apart from my ally of course, there are only two people who can see you, and who you can notice. It is me and Silent Scream . So you better be nice to your granddaughter... The older one, because if you want to know, you have another one, but you will probably never meet, because I see no reason to bring her to this place, let alone introduce you to her.” You turned to the terrified woman, and made another gesture, the second spell she had prepared for this time. This time, a round hole appeared on the ceiling, like a window to another world, from where a howling Wind began to blow. Everyone saw gigantic mountains, the vastness of which seemed difficult to understand. It suddenly became incredibly cold, and then for a moment a monstrous figure stood over the port, as gigantic as the peaks among which it walked. It had the body of a spider, but also a monstrous face, almost looking like the face of a humanoid. Atlah- Naha, weaving through worlds, Spinner of the Void. The goddess of their people, perhaps... Then the window closed, and she herself called off the

darkness. She felt incredibly tired, and almost withdrew to the floor. But then her sister, as they had agreed, stepped forward to the front of the terrified courtiers and cried out

“Long live Shadow Weaver! First mother of the Yago clan”

Perhaps power is just smoke and shadows.

Chapter End Notes

Here is the next chapter. Please share your comments and opinions.

Everything in the Universe is a Resource - Part One

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Calamity stretched her back. One of the advantages of her physique was that her joints Never Creaked. She could hardly tell how much more pleasant it made her life, for after all she felt almost no pain, and so she was glad of it. It was one of countless proofs of her superiority over mere mortals, of her divine origin...

She waited on the plateau for her support. It irritated her a little that she had to wait for the sorceress, but she also knew that she needed her help, and not just because of the orders of the Creeping Chaos, although she could not oppose them. Her summoning skills were limited, so Nightgale could prove invaluable. Besides, she was the only one who had contact with this fascinating elf. She felt a little jealous about it, but she figured it could be a kind of test for her, to test her patience and humility. She knew she didn't have many flaws, but one could say she had a tendency to overestimate her own abilities, nothing serious, of course, and it was completely understandable for a being as incredibly magnificent as she was, but sometimes she forgot her own limitations. After all, she wasn't a goddess... yet.

Ever since she killed the owner of that tower, her companions watched her with fear, And that was good. Mortals must remember who they should show fear to. She only regretted that now that girl was not too willing to respond to her dizziness, but that was only a minor obstacle, The world was full of beautiful women and men, and the goal was to get to know that wonderful elf. Perhaps they would even have offspring, so magnificent and wonderful, before which the whole universe would tremble!

She was just starting to yawn when she saw the vehicle approaching.. She was glad that this planet was so chaotic and poorly organized that traveling even for someone as sought-after as she or her companions was not difficult. She personally would make it so that anyone who left their place of residence would have to provide a good reason to do so, otherwise he and his entire family would face terrible punishment. Everyone knew that the basis of a properly functioning justice system was collective responsibility and intimidation of the citizens.

As the vehicle approached, she noticed that it was not piloted by Nightgale, but by someone she had not noticed at first. Only after a moment did she see that at the controls was a black metal cylinder with various metal tentacles, with which he held the control instruments. She guessed that this was the ally that Nightgale had spoken of . However, she did not see the sorcerer anywhere... Until the vehicle was close to them and she saw Nighgale lying on its floor. Apparently, she had to fight for control of the moonstone again. She felt uneasy. Shadow Weaver's daughter was key to their plans, and on top of that, she enjoyed the favor of the Creeping Chaos. So she approached her and watched her carefully. The sorceress moved slowly and was clearly exhausted. She remembered what ordinary mortals did in such a situation and put her hand to her forehead. The daughter of the cursed sorceress was cold and wet. No wonder, she had heard from Shadow Weaver about how much she had suffered every time when she had lost her connection to Black Garnet. Personally, she considered that weakness to be another reason to hold the woman in contempt, but the fact that her daughter had fought for control of the moonstone with Glimmer, who she had to grudgingly admit, held considerable power.

"Get something warming, now!" she ordered a pair of cultists who without delay they began to carry out Her orders, and in the meantime She took Nightgale in her arms and carried her to their small camp and covered her with a blanket. Then they gave her a glass of wine, And broth began to boil on the fire. The young sorceress groaned and rose, She began to look around with tired eyes, And then she said.

„This time Glimmer was exceptionally stubborn... She probably looks much better than me, but she won't have the strength to try for a while, although from what I've heard she's a very stubborn woman. She won't give up easily... „ her voice was hoarse and you could hear how difficult a fight she had to fight.

„But you are ready to go on your way?„ she asked anxiously, but Shadow Weaver's daughter gave her a strange look, as if she wanted to accuse her of something, and said.

"I'm half horde clone, and they were built to endure hardships that would kill most beingand my mother is just as tough. I can handle it, I just need some rest."

„Good, because first you need to contact our allies... Or at least mine, because whether he took the alliance with you, we'll see. „ said the metal cylinder, who with surprising agility crawled to them. She had heard quite a lot about such beings , and they were more interesting. She knew that inside it was a living brain placed there by the Mi-Go, one of the older and more interesting races. Mortals wanting to prolong their existence could really grab at strange methods, but now she was grateful. She could use the help of one of the Elder Races, as well as someone with these lower abilities, especially since Lady Sorrowflame was not nearby, and besides, even she did not have the knowledge of the void wanderers.

"It's good to see you... Dr. Moors, isn't it? Once my companion is back to normal, we will contact your allies. Thank you also for taking care of my… friend.." She smiled at him and held out her hand.

„I didn't expect you to call me that.„ Nightgale said, looking at her carefully. She smiled at her politely, and said.

„You are important to me, so I can call you friend."

"However, friends are just one more resource that you can use to achieve your goals, your mother saw that all too well."

She was breathing heavily wrapped in a blanket. She tried to regain control over the moonstone, and again she failed. This time she fought longer and more persistently than before, Perhaps, but the one who fought had an iron will. No wonder, after all, she was Shadow Weaver's daughter, and she knew the woman well enough to know that she was so determined that she could overcome any difficulties... Perhaps apart from the feeling of guilt, but she didn't tell anyone about that, because no one would understand, not even her father, who knew her from the best side. She was very sorry that he wasn't here. She could see that he supported her with his knowledge. Or at least the Council... It wasn't just about regaining control over the stone, but also about everything. In a few hours, their situation changed Diametrically. Allies turned out to be enemies, a new threat arose that she had no idea how to deal with, a friend was Cursed, and another gave in to her anger. In addition, there was still the matter of her child, although paradoxically it seemed to be the simplest In this matter, she decided to trust the Knight of Hell's opinion, even though it seemed strange, and unless new circumstances arise, she will probably give birth to this child. She smiled sadly and touched her stomach, at least one thing was going well. At that moment Bow stepped into the tent frightened by what she looked like.

„Are you okay?„ he asked her as he hugged her tightly and she smiled weakly and said.

„Nothing, absolutely nothing. I just tried to do it again, to regain control of it again... Over my runestone, But I failed, but it's only a matter of time... And I don't need it for now, because that way I wouldn't get into Castle Crypto ... „ She explained, smiling at him comfortingly, and he patted her on the head and said.

„I'm not sure if you're comforting me or yourself. I know how hard it is for you, because you've always loved your power, and used it every chance you got. Maybe we'll actually have to find a way to make peace with Lonnie, because we have to take care of you and the Baby... If you keep having to wrestle with that Nightgale,

something might happen to you... or both of you.„ he kissed her on the forehead, she said to him with a smile, and then I'm sorry and they sat like that for a while, but then Adora entered the tent. She understood at first glance that something had happened.

"Is this something with Catra?" She asked, afraid that something had happened to her feline friend, because she remembered that she didn't always deal well with anger, and when she left her tent she was clearly furious . Maybe she was judging her unfairly, but she was really worried.

„No, I mean, yes, but it's a bit different than you think. Listen, Frosta flew to Castle Crypto to meet with that sorceress... You know, her daughter... Shadow Weaver's daughter... And Catra decided to go after her... She contacted her father's people, Lady Ka and the rest . „ The Warrior explained, breathing heavily, apparently having run straight to them. She was in human form, and a storm was raging outside, so she was definitely tired, despite her excellent condition, especially since she had been on her feet all day and half the night anyway. Hearing this news, she jumped to her feet, although she was just as exhausted, and called out.

„But how? Why did she go there... I'm talking about Frosta...”

"She could have heard what we were talking about, honey..." her husband stated, and she groaned, rubbing her face with her hands. Adora nodded, and said.

„I'm not sure what you were talking about, but something really shook her up... But it's probably not your fault, because she was also talking to Halo, and we all heard what She told her.

She rubbed her temples and said.

„We have to stop her somehow, or rather both of them... Netossa.. „ She wanted to say, but Adora interrupted her.

„Well, actually, Netossa went with her too... and Seahawk and the rest... They will manage, and if necessary I can come there…, and

if necessary I can come there... I've already done it once and from another planet, so it should be easier now.„ She said, smiling as if you wanted to calm her down. She sank into an armchair, And her husband said.

„I would perhaps send a few ships, just in case, to help them if anything happens.”

She nodded, and for a moment she pondered over her further orders, but then one of the messengers came in and said.

„ We have received a message from outside the empire… And they do not seem to be working with the Grand Marshal's father. They claim to be from the Azlanti Star Empire……

She recognized that word... That name... Adora had told her about them . They were the people who had enslaved her mother... She felt a rage take hold of her, a rage she couldn't describe. In that moment, she understood what Catra had always felt... This desire to vent your hatred on the one who hurt you. Even when the war was going on and the Heart of Etheria was activated, she didn't feel this much anger... Back then, she was rather helpless and desperate. Maybe it was because so much had happened... Or maybe because now she was faced with pure evil, with a civilization that embodied everything that was against the values they believed in. Even the Horde wasn't that wicked, because after all, its evil came from a single, crazy megalomaniac, and if Lady Cala was to be believed, even he was a victim of sorts, even if that was hard to fathom. And they were all sincerely devoted to the evil on which they based their society... They were like the First... She instinctively glanced at Adora, who was watching her closely, waiting for her answer. Bow was watching her too, but he smiled and placed his hand on her shoulder. She took a deep breath and said in a very cold voice, as cold as the wind that was raging outside.

"I will listen to them... And I will prepare them the welcome they deserve."

Lord Protector Felix Antares marched with his guards through the streets of the recently captured city.. It was the first conquest… No, that wasn’t the right word. After all, he had come here as a liberator, and as a liberator he should see himself, even if it was otherwise. Appearances required great concentration, one must always be careful not to step out of character, because otherwise one could ruin the work one had put into his preciously created image. Of course, one must always be careful not to forget that in the end, exercising power is mostly a game, smoke and shadows… Many believed in the lies about you, spread them. For example, the madman Horde Prime, who truly believed that he knew everything and saw everything. And where is he now? He was defeated by his daughter's wife, because he believed he was invincible... So he couldn't allow himself to believe that he had come here to save the inhabitants of this part of the Galaxy, after all, morality walked before the fall... However, he had to take great care to ensure that no one knew the truth until everything was ready, including his daughter. If he carries out his plans well, then by the time they began to see the truth, he would have gained such a strong position that no one would be able to oppose him. He just had to figure out how to convince his daughter of all this, which might be difficult, but if he played this right, which would leave her with a fait accompli. Sometimes it was necessity that made the best leaders.

They were on the planet Minos Secondus , which was once a colony founded by the inhabitants of Icarus, but which had won independence from the mother world, but had soon fallen into a period of turmoil, as a result of which the local communist party and fundamentalist theocracy took over the power there, which fought for years until Horde Prime arrived, and ended all disputes in a clear and final way. The planet served as a place where the fleet could take supplies. Before, the Colony had made its profits mainly from producing fuel for ships, now it was all about the sole reason for its existence. Initially, most of the inhabitants were relocated to the refineries orbiting the gas giant, but some had to stay on the planet to supply the refineries, and probably also so

that the mad Tyrant had something to rule. When Horde Prime was annihilated by his Daughter-in-law workers in refineries staged a successful revolt, but the clones dug in for the planet, leading to a strange stalemate, because those in space did not have the means to retake the planet, but the clones were unable to do anything to them, but only until the Heavenly Brothers arrived with their fleet. However, then the leader of the rebels named Emerald Sun decided to mine all the refineries, and also contacted Horde Ultimate, offering him fuel in exchange for support. The self-proclaimed heir arrived, and began fighting his rivals, but the leaders of the uprising did not call him for access to the refineries, although they provided him with fuel to exchange for food supplies. The Heavenly Brothers tried to retake the planet from time to time, but they did not achieve much, so it was divided between both factions, and the rebels hiding in the wild, independent of the Emerald Sun Subordinates. The leader of the uprising tried to contact Etheria, but he did not have his own ships, and no one was sure how loyal he was to Horde Ultimate, so the other parties opposing the power of the heirs of the mad tyrant did not want to risk cooperation with him. However, he decided to do it. After all, in war you have to take risks to win, And have good intelligence, this cannot be forgotten either. Lady Ka hired several pirates from outside the empire, the fact that they were able to sneak through the border guards of Veskarium or Azlanti, so Avoiding Horde Ultimate patrols was not difficult. The insurgents trapped on the refineries agreed to his support and provided him with all the information he needed. The pirates, as well as his Scouts, obtained intelligence data related to the planet for him, and it turned out that he chose the perfect time, because Horde Ultimate began to withdraw from your force, leaving the planet to their rivals. He guessed that Horde Ultimate knew that this planet could be the next place Fearless Armada would decide to attack, so he didn't want to waste his army in a two-front fight, and now he allowed him to defeat his opponents. He appreciated the common sense of the Heir of the mad lord, and sent this fleet. The few ships that decided here were easily destroyed by Commander Rees, who also led the invasion. So

when he returned from his daughter's wedding, he only had to specify the choking points of permanent resistance.

The planet was never densely populated. Due to the long civil wars, few colorists came here, and many died during the fighting or were killed by the Horde's forces... Now there were mainly farms, food processing plants and biofuel production, as well as a transshipment port used to deliver supplies to the refinery. The enemy destroyed the port, but apart from that the city did not suffer too much damage here. The servants of the Heavenly Brothers hid in old abandoned mines, where they defended themselves for some time until they managed to bring heavy artillery and then sent special forces, namely his Orphans of the Void, thanks to which they managed to break up and the enemies withdrew to remote regions of the planets, where his army could count on the support of local rebels who were hiding there during the occupation. The fighting had practically stopped and now it was time to plan for the future, but it was not as bright as it might seem.

It was another easy victory, but there would be no more like it, not with the forces he had now… He had to dig in and hold out until he gained support, and gaining it was not so certain. He still had not received word from the Pact Worlds and Atrax, where the rest of his forces were. He also knew that his daughter's country now had its own problems related to rebellion, so he lent them his forces so that it could be quickly suppressed. He also could not forget the young queen's reluctance, but he already had an idea on how to solve her problem… There was no doubt that his daughter deserved the throne more, and once she took power, he would be able to use all of Etheria's resources to achieve his goals. This planet had a fleet acquired on Horde Prime, as well as battle-hardened veterans. He could not forget its political significance either, because by gaining its support, he would also gain influence on the industrially developed Ikarus, as well as on Bellum, which had a powerful army. The other planets in Etheria’s sphere of influence were no longer as important, nor could support be useful. Of course, he did not count on Lady Sorrowflame making great discoveries on this planet, because he

had never believed that one should place one's hopes in ancient artifacts and mystical secrets. In this matter, he counted more on his troops left on the planet... Lady. Ka made mistakes, for which she had recently been punished, but she usually carried out her duties extremely carefully. He had no doubt that she would be able to solve the problem of the Insurgents, and perhaps the remaining issues... For now, however, he had to wait. Battles could be won with heroism and great tactics, but to win a war, resources were needed above all. He was an intelligent man, and he knew that everything in the Universe was a resource, not only raw materials or an army, but also political connections, public support, morale, friends, family, absolutely everything was just a resource, but many of them were difficult to replace, and sometimes even irreplaceable... they could not be squandered...

He was accompanied by only two guards, and of course his Wolf Resh, and even so he thought that it was more than enough. He never liked being surrounded by bodyguards… That would mean he was afraid, and fear was a weakness he could not tolerate... He also liked fighting, in the heat of battle he felt that he was truly alive. Then his fate depended only on him, he was the one who took life. It was also a kind of power, power over those to whom he brought death. As they said, killing a Million with an order is statistics, but killing someone in a face-to-face fight is a true Triumph Worthy of a Great Man. Here, however, there was nothing to indicate that he would have to fight. Thinking about his further rights, feeling safe and bored.

And then a blaster beam hit the soldier walking right next to him. He didn't have time to groan as he fell pierced by the energy beam. He grabbed his weapon, in one hand he held a saber and in the other a destructor-class pistol. He looked for shelter, in two leaps he found himself in a side street, then he looked around and saw one of the opponents standing on the roof. He was a clone, but dressed in different armor, red and gold, heavy and more expensively made. From the reports he received through his intel, he presumed this is a soldier serving the Horde Ultimate. He smiled to himself, seeing such an ingenious trap. He didn't think that the heir to Horde Prime would turn out to be so cunning. He

saw in it the hand of his Drow second-in-command, but still because he was impressed. But now he had to survive, And he heard the footsteps of the other soldiers, here they are hidden to surround him. He sent backup, but he knew it wouldn't come fast enough, so he had to get out of the encirclement himself. He ordered the soldier next to him to cover him, and together with his nightmare hunter ran into the tenement house, Next to which they stopped, using a pistol to break the lock on the door. He had to buy time, Or fight all the opponents who wanted to take his life. Either way, he needed a more convenient shelter to be able to defend himself, although on the other hand he knew that in this way he would be surrounded, But he took this risk. However, an opponent shot at him on the stairwell, the clone fired a lighter Blaster at him, but it did not penetrate his shield, and then the Nightmare Hunter jumped at him, crushing his hand in its cybernetically enhanced jaws. He ran up the stairs, and there he lay in wait, when another clone tried to enter, he fired a pistol at him. If it had been a normal pistol, nothing would have happened, because it hit next to him, but this was a radiation-based weapon, much more destructive, and practically forbidden in many worlds of fact. The radiation wave didn't have to hit exactly to do damage, at least with the weapon's settings, and the clone's body began to drip with dissolved skin. A truly inhuman scream was heard, and then he fell to the ground. He signaled his wolf, who was just finishing off the first attacker, to run after him. The door above was open, and a family lay tied up on the floor, and another of the Horde Ultimate soldiers jumped on him from the other room.. He grabbed him by the forearm and broke his arm, in which he held the gun. He effortlessly stopped the pain, he was unusually resistant to it after being shot and plunged the blade of the weapon into the clone's stomach and pushed it away with a knee strike, and his companion tore out his throat. He looked out the window discreetly, and saw the other assassins preparing to attack. He cursed, because he knew it would be a difficult fight, but somehow he had to manage. But then the expected help arrived.

There were six attackers, all armed, at least two had heavy weapons. He knew that you should hide in the depths of the building now, because there would probably be nothing left of this apartment, but he hesitated. Not because he was ashamed to hide here, leaving his family here, after all, he tried to avoid accidental destruction when he freed this city, but he felt a strange curiosity, as if he wanted to see what would happen. He realized that it was a mental impulse, and he felt uneasy, but before he could react, a figure ran between the enemy soldiers. He couldn't get a good look at her. She moved incredibly fast. Faster than any human could, as if she was tearing through and around her. She made a howling whistle as she did so. She dealt blows, knocking down enemies one by one. She struck with a long and incredibly sharp sword, with a narrow blade that cut the attackers in half with each strike. The fight lasted only a few heartbeats, until the figure finally knocked down almost all of the clones, leaving the last one alive.

„What are you waiting for, why don't you kill me?„ said the other, clutching his arm, but his other hand was hidden under a long coat. The figure he was talking to was tall, had a red coat with the emblem of his family, on his face was a strange mask, consisting of many metal parts, so that they could move to simulate a real face, her hair was long, dark red, and under the coat he could see that she had prosthetics made of a strange metal that reminded him of something, but from this distance where he was sure what.

„You will not die now. You will pass on my word to your master. Tell him that Despara is coming for him, and will take his life, but first he will see everything he loves, and everything that belongs to him. For this is how victories are won. „ she said and with two quick cuts deprived him of his limbs. The wounds did not bleed, as if something had burned his limbs. Then the figure looked at the figure looked at the place where he was hiding and gave him a sign, and he went down. for a moment he hesitated ... and then he went down.

Chapter End Notes

Here's another chapter, and again a two-parter. I'm using a quote from Fadding Suns in the title. I invite you to leave comments and opinions.

Everything in the universe is a resource - Part Two

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It was cold outside. She really shouldn't be out in her condition. Even with her thermal suit, she still felt cold, and her face burned as if someone was stabbing her with thousands of icy needles. She could barely keep her teeth from chattering. Bow was holding her up, or she would probably be carried away by the wind, or at least that was the impression she had. Adora walked beside her with cold determination, as if she was ready to face the icy storm and not even slow down. She no longer wore the armor given to her by the Lord Admiral, but it seemed that it didn't matter to her. So much had happened in the past few hours that everyone was wishing for a little sleep, but there was one more task ahead of them, perhaps the most difficult one for her at any given time.

They finally managed to reach the communication center, Although she thought she would never make it, she would simply get lost in her own camp and freeze, the most idiotic death of all the queens of Etheria, and maybe even the queens of the Galaxy. Rarely did the heat hit her with such force that she lost her breath. She suspected that it wasn't that warm at all, it just seemed like it to her, because she had been frozen to the bone earlier. She wiped her forehead and said.

„What news has reached you? Is it something serious?”

Onyx Sky looked at her and smiled reassuringly.

„It's just greetings and assurances of friendly intentions, and a request to meet at a convenient time.„ they explained as she sat down on a chair. The room was quite tight, but there was still

enough room for the three of them. She looked at it, smiling sadly. They did not know the truth about Azlanti, and what they did to her mother and their queen... They did not know how despicable the inhabitants of this country were. I can for most of the inhabitants of her planet, everyone who came from outside Horde Prime's Empire seemed fascinating, and friendly, after all, they had a common enemy, and in addition, the leader of the research and exploration fleet was the father of one of their heroines, and therefore the father-in-law of She-Ra herself. They had no reason to suspect anyone of evil intentions. Perhaps Lonnie was right in her call to cut themselves off from the rest of the Galaxy , but unless they found a way to return to Despondos again they would have to remain where they were, and deal with being part of an infinitely large and terrifying Universe. Onyx Sky began working on the Apparatus, then signaled for them to come over.

„The quality is not perfect, to put it mildly, due to the storm, and perhaps the jamming devices that the signal encountered.. And also the specifics of your planet. It seems to me that twelve moons can interfere with the operation of... probably everything. I have to do some research on this subject sometime.„ said the person from Icarus to herself and moved away from the Screen. At first, there was only interference and the entire room resounded with painful noises, which made her wince. But then a figure appeared on the screen. She looked like a woman, it was tall and well-built. It was dressed in blue armor with green decorations, hair tied in a braid and two curved swords on jer shoulders. On hers head, it wore a tiara of green metal with a white stone emanating an inner glow. She smiled at them benevolently. It seemed strangely familiar to her, but she could not determine why, but when she looked at Adora out of the corner of her eye she saw that she had turned pale She was about to ask her about what happened but then the woman started speaking.

„Greetings to the people of Horde Prime's former empire . I am Seleste Sirianix – Protoatarch of the Great Azlantii Star Empire Azlantia. I came here at the head of an Expeditionary Fleet sent

here by our great Star Emperors to bring Pax Azlantica to this nonhuman-ravaged part of the galaxy. We know that this place has suffered for millennia from the tyranny of an insane non-human, and also from the lack of guidance by those chosen for it. The human species in particular suffered because it was deprived of the chance to fulfill its destiny, which is where the leadership of the lesser races lies, because they are incapable of independent leadership, so easily subject to their savage instincts. We know that non-humans are not worse than us, but simply destined for different purposes, and only their speciesism and the blindness of the fanatical ideology of their leaders force them to act contrary to the natural order of things. This region of the Galaxy is special for another reason . For it was the home of one of the greatest branches of our species, the civilization called the First Ones. They created a mighty Empire, the wonders of which were difficult for moderns to imagine. Sadly, while seemingly following a similar path to the great Star Empire, they have made grave mistakes, most notably by betraying the gods and rejecting their teachings, and thus their empire was doomed to fall. We, the Azlanti, do not follow this path, for we are the only ones worthy of bearing the destiny of the human species on our shoulders. We are the heirs of all the branches of humanity that have ever existed, but have failed to secure our species its rightful place at the forefront of the sentient species of the Galaxy. Some of you may doubt our words, but look to Etheria if you need proof. It was a member of our kind who defeated the leader of the dreadful, speciesist , non-human Empire. She did so by returning to her Legacy, and became the embodiment of all the virtues of our species! It is to her that we turn, to aid us in bringing here true Pax. Azlantika. We believe that, like us, he has the best interests of his species and all the people of this place at heart and will join our great empire so that we can carry the light of human destiny to the farthest corners of the Galaxy. So we turn to She-Ra, the heroine of the Galaxy, to come to our aid, for we share the same blood, and I believe that in the end we all want the same things, for good to prevail and for peace to reign in the Galaxy..„ explain the message was interrupted. For a moment She breathed heavily and then screamed.

„Let them stick these assurances of peace so deep that they couldn't even get them out with a poker! What the fuck is this! We've all always been together here, and they believe... They believe that one species has the right to rule over all, and those who disagree are called speciesists.„ She threw out a long and very nasty string of curses that made her husband blush. Adora, however, seemed shaken. She said quietly under her breath.

„The same blood flows in our veins...„ Her gaze was absent... Bow placed her hand on the Shoulder of the Princess of Power, and said.

„It doesn't mean anything, after all we are all Etherians regardless of which people we belong to.

But Adora looked at them, with a sadness bordering on despair in her eyes, and said.

„Don't you see that? You haven't talked to her as many times as I have... This woman... this Seleste is Mara... „ and she sat down in the chair as if she had lost all her strength.

Calamity frowned at all the moons. Even though she was not gifted with developed magical abilities, she could sense the powers emanating from them. What's more, she could determine their nature. They were connected to the main planes, as well as the elemental planes, which was both interesting and irritating. The Outer Gods and the Great Old Ones existed long before the planes were created. It must have been a powerful source of power, but it remained beyond her reach, and beyond the reach of most of the inhabitants of this planet, at least until recently. This worried her, because if they managed to harness the magic of the moons, then in the future it would not only be the Princesses who could be a problem.

"He says his planet is similar... Magic comes from primal sources... He thinks the two worlds are connected in some way, though he's

not sure how. That's why they were the First Ones to take an interest in them." Nightgale explained. The girl looked better, though of course she was always pale in her natural form, but she was straight and didn't tremble, so she was probably better. The Elf stood next to her, looking around curiously. She still thought she'd never seen anyone so attractive.

„That's interesting, and logical...„ she wondered, because she knew very little about his planet, and she was not sure if she wanted to know more, because she suspected that it was as boring and full of fools as Etheria. However, she was ordered to go there, so she had no choice but to do it. She looked at Doctor Moors and asked.

„I heard that your allies prefer to appear on a moonless night, but it's hard to find one here... Won't the light bother them?”

The steel cylinder made a strange sound which only a moment later she recognized as laughter and said.

„They never had a problem with the sun or the moon, it's just that on such nights it's harder to see the void wanderes traveling through the night sky.„ said the brain in cylinder, and she nodded and waited. Of course, she was ready to pick him out of this can, if his friends tried to betray her... Or didn't show up at all. Sometimes you had to show people that you weren't to be joked with.

They appeared silently. Straight on long, neither insect nor membranous wings. There were four of them, two of them were larger and had powerful pincers from which tentacles grew that wrapped around strange bionic weapons. The rest were smaller. One had several visible cracks in its skeleton, and the other had a long antenna growing from the center of its body.. This seemed to be the commander here, so she nodded at him and said.

„You are the commander here, aren't you? I am Calamity , spawn of the Great Outer God Yog-Sototh, Perfection incarnate. You are honored to meet me! she said, drawing her weapon.

She made a certain impression, for the member of the ancient race made a strange chirping sound, and a voice echoed in her head.

"I am the Overseer of this facility, and I came here to make a deal with you. We recently tried to make an alliance with the local People's Rebellion, but it didn't go well. Ordinary mortals don't make good allies if they can't be controlled. They focus so much on their emotions and morals that they forget what really matters in life. For example, we asked them to give us a certain thing, we want to get the brain of a certain woman... A certain exceptional and very intelligent woman, whose intelligence is widely known throughout the planet." He said, and she raised an eyebrow and looked at the Sorceress, then asked.

„Is she talking about who I think he is talking about?”

Nightgale looked down and answered her with obvious confusion, as if she was hiding a sense of guilt.

„I guessed it, although not right away. Comrade General told us about it, because she knew that no one would agree with her. Entrapta may be our enemy, although now I'm not entirely sure, but she wouldn't want something like that to happen to her. We are not... Rebels are not monsters.„ she threw a sharp look at Dr. Moors. She laughed briefly at the sorcerer's words, and then she said.

"You both surprised me. Who would have guessed that this animal's former friend could be so cunning to seek out her subordinates and so determined to make such an arrangement.. And as for you, I didn't expect you to show any scruples towards that woman. She is in a way your stepmother… Her child is your sister, they lives your life, which could have been yours if your father had taken care of you. And yet, you don't want her to come to harm." She shook her head pityingly, and Dr. Moors added.

„It wouldn't even be a harm, but something wonderful. I can vouch that in this state I feel much better, and besides, thanks to

this her mind would be preserved for eternity!„ At the last words he practically shouted, so She signaled him to be silent, because she had more important matters to discuss, and turned to the overseer.

„And as for you, what are you demanding and what are you offering?”

„I admit that our species has always been cautious about working with the Great Old Ones and Outer Gods. Their power is indeed Great, but their minds are alien even to us, making them unpredictable. Perhaps we have no choice in this matter, but it seems we should find out what you have to offer us.” Said Overseer

She smiled at the creature, briefly considering whether she should kill his companions to show him who was boss, but she could do that later if she grew dissatisfied or bored.. Instead, she told it of the reason they had come here. She told it of their First Ones plots and the new threat, which the overseer probably hadn't even heard of. It took a good hour, but everyone listened attentively to her comma, and when she finished, they were silent for a moment, Until finally the leader of the Mi-Go said.

„So our old enemy hasn't left... And he threatens our kind... This is indeed disturbing news... Perhaps this will be enough for you to form an alliance... A common enemy is always a good reason to cooperate, Or at least such an enemy...„ He said, emanating Thoughtfulness, as well as fear, which vibrated disturbingly in her mind. Should she also be afraid of the First Ones? She felt no fear, not even of this She-Ra, but she understood that certain things could destroy her, and the First Ones were definitely able to do it... They could destroy not only her, but also take away everything that was precious to her... Forever take away her ability to fulfill her destiny. At that moment, she began to feel in her heart the seed of a germinating feeling that she knew so well... Hatred, deep and full of passion. And yet it is from hatred that the most magnificent things are made...

„I will have to leave this place soon, and I will not return soon, and in the next few months I will probably not visit this planet. I am not sure if it will be a problem in further relations... I intend to go to a planet called Xadia ... It is a very distant place, and we do not know its location... However, thanks to him, we will be able to Free one of our allies. A powerful sorcerer called Aaravos , the chosen one of Nyarlathotep, who was created by the first ones, but fought them to liberate his planet, as well as himself. Perhaps, we will also be able to create our own Bloodstone... „ she explained, but now she felt a wave of Unrest coming from the Overseer.

„That's not a very good idea, because I remember what bloodstones were, and from what I recall they caused destruction on a scale that is hard to imagine... I don't see the logic in repeating this experiment...”

„Don't worry, it will be a damaged bloodstone. Like after a lobotomy, nothing that would be able to act independently, nor try to rebel. The Creeping Chaos has foreseen such an eventuality, and has protected itself against it. „ she explained in a gentle voice, but he seemed not entirely convinced, so he said.

„I will send a Connector with you. He will pass on reports to me, and he will do it in real time. If he dies, or something similar happens to him, I will consider it a betrayal and will try to thwart all your plans. I have established contact with the rest of our diaspora, and if we consider that your actions threaten us, we have to destroy the Blodstone , and perhaps the entire planet. However, if it is as you say, then we will help you. As you know, our species does not need ordinary spaceships, we are able to cross the void, and believe me, they were able to do it very quickly. I have knowledge of Xadia , although it is Pabich genetic, but it is still clear enough for me to know, come from our outposts there was. The liaison will not only allow us, and perhaps the Mi-Go to go there, but it will also allow you to establish cooperation with the local branch of our race. „ The Overseer spoke in her mind, and it took only her willpower to stop herself from ripping

him in half for threatening her… instead she said, still smiling gently.

„That's good, but you should have asked for more. My resources are limited at the moment, and from what I understand you've prepared a lot of valuable equipment for the rebels, so could you share it with us, okay?„ When she finished, and then the Overseer laughed, and her companions, except for Dr. Moors, winced in pain, and then he ordered the smallest of the Mi-Go to Hand him a certain item, which he passed to her. It looked like a flat centipede with a very long spike at the end, and a bracelet was attached to the other end.

„Observing Horde Prime's activities has led me to the conclusion that controlling chipped people can be useful in many ways. This is one such device based on reverse engineering of the mad Tyrant's chips, as well as our previous research. It can be separated into two parts, a bracelet and a controller. With the bracelet, you will be able to mentally control the person to whom this controller is attached.”

She smiled as so many possibilities now appeared in her mind…

„ Is this the only device of its kind? If you have more, I suggest you use it on a certain person...„ the evil glow in her eyes made her companions step back from her.

They spent another hour discussing the minor details of their agreement, and then the Mi”Go flew away, leaving them as if they had never met. She wanted to go to sleep, after such a successful negotiation, but then Nightgale approached her, and said, holding out her hand.

„Your ring… Give it to me, as agreed.”

She looked at it in surprise, because she had almost forgotten about the agreement. She looked at the ring and took it off her hand, but hesitated. She usually didn't share what she got with anyone, even when she was just a larva called a child.

„Maybe we'd better wait until we get to Krannor Rill...”

The young sorcerer looked at her coldly, and held out her hand.

„If our cooperation is to continue smoothly, I would prefer to receive this ring now, especially since it will be more practical in many ways.„ she said in a calm but firm voice. She bit her lip, fighting with herself, but then handed the ring to Nightgale . Shadow Weaver's daughter looked at it for a moment, then put it on. It was a bit too tight, but after a moment it adjusted to the diameter of her fingers.

„Thank you. It would make our work much more difficult for you if we were to argue about something like this now. I understand you, such artifacts are extremely valuable resources, but also remember that each such thing is associated with a price, which must be paid. Power also has its price, and it is very rare to check that the others will pay it. In such a game as we are playing now, we must remember that we are only resources, and perhaps we will even be the prize someday.”

She shuddered at the words of the sorceress.

Lord Protector Felix Antares allowed his savior to dress his hand. Soon the priests would arrive, who would use their magic to heal it... He had suffered much more serious wounds in battle, and even outside of it, as evidenced by his asymmetrical face. He watched her silently, wondering who she was. Most likely she was an ally, otherwise she would have tried to kill him by now... Then again, allies are often just future enemies.

After a moment, his Warrior was joined by an android who had come out of the post office and the gate. She looked strange, her body was covered in many scars that formed symbols that he could not read. She had no ears, or ear holes. She was dressed in armor that looked like it was made of leather, and it tightly hugged her body. She had no visible weapon, not even the self-

defense pistol they usually carried, since they couldn't always cast the spell in time.. Dozens of tiny metal balls floated around her. She walked up to the Warrior Girl, and then the balls began to form symbols, but he couldn't read them either, though they seemed to be in the Drow language, the girl with the metal prosthetics nodded a few times, and then said something in sign language, and her companion stood to one side, and began to watch her balls with surprising fascination, and she herself walked up to him and said.

"Ivi says they had a transport nearby, well hidden, but she got rid of it and everyone guarding it." She spoke calmly, almost without passion, her voice surprisingly methodical . He raised an eyebrow at the android , but he wasn't really surprised that she could handle a military unit. There was something about her that suggested she was just as dangerous as her companion.

„Interesting, I expected it to be a suicide mission. They aren't as fanatical as they were in Horde Prime's time . I wonder if it's degeneration or maybe progress...„ he looked into the woman's eyes, and noticed that they were made of metal... Unusual, because most usually tried to make their new cybernetic eyes look real. But of course he used the traditional external lens, in this woman's case it made an exceptionally Eerie impression, because you could read absolutely nothing from her gaze.

"Who exactly are you, and what are you doing here?" he finally said after a moment, letting it dry. The woman tilted her head to the side and said.

„As you've heard, my name is Despara, but that probably means nothing to you. Nominally, I'm an enforcer of House Drait , but I currently command a portion of your Armada, after Markus was murdered by assassins sent by politicians of the Atrax government , who are jealous of your influence. And before you ask, I've already solved their problem. I have access to the best assassins on Apostate.”

He took a deep breath, because this was shocking news. He wasn't sure if he should call Markus his friend, but he was one of the few he had left after being banished. He felt a sadness, more of a nostalgia than a loss of someone close. Well, Markus had apparently found a replacement for himself, unless of course this girl was responsible for his death. He couldn't rule it out, in an organization like his army, there were sometimes personal frictions, and rivalries were sometimes downright deadly. Personally, he never approved of this type of behavior, because it often distracted his subordinates from their tasks, but when he was this far away, he couldn't help it. Apparently, in this case, he had to accept the facts.

„So reinforcements have arrived, right?„ that thought definitely chased away the sadness of losing his comrade. He finally had all his forces under his control. He would be able to fight on a full scale. His recent worries were forgotten.

„Not only Antares . I managed to win over several Drow corporations to your cause, primarily Night Dragon belonging to House Drait . In addition to the usual forces of the corporation and the Drow noble house, I also brought you thirty thousand orc mercenaries. I also managed to gain increased support from Absalom's troops. The son of the Archduke of Carurystal also came here with a private army, which he acquired in circumstances that are difficult to define. Also the temple of Damoritosh agreed to support your case. In a word, your forces in this region of the Galaxy have doubled, and even speaking of the Fleet... Actually, I forgot about the Order Of The Eclipse, which came here with all its forces, But they are not subject to your command, but still it is something."

Hearing what she said several times. Now it turned out that his situation was much better than he could have ever dreamed. He smiled for the first time in many years.

„So Despara , Welcome to the Fearless Armada… „ he said, and only now he realized what her limbs were. He felt uneasy,

because Lady Sorrowflame had told him how incredibly valuable they could be.

„Who are you? Despara. That can't be your real name... „ he asked a bit uncertainly.

„ No... My sister called me Smiley, because I think I like smiling. „ her plates of her mask arranged themselves so that it seemed that she was smiling. And then she took off and he saw a familiar” looking face. Her cheeks were cut, so that the scars reached all the way to the cat's ears. Her face was covered with strange tattoos, looking as if they were connected constellations, and in the yellow cat's eyes he saw amusement. „But you, Dad, you can call me daughter.”

Chapter End Notes

This time it went faster, I invite you to comment and leave your opinion.
Who guessed the identity of Despara?

Breather

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

„Okay, now it's time for the tests!„ Entrapta called out and squealed so loudly that she had to lay her ears down.

„Have you ever thought about using your voice as a sonic weapon?„ she said rubbing her ears. The inventor looked at her, then her eyes lit up , and she said in a voice full of excitement.

„Oh! That's a great idea! I'll get on it right away!„ And she started typing something on her datapad, completely ignoring the rest.

"Sorry, but I think we were supposed to test Eti's hand now, right? „ Alatar asked tiredly. They were in the training room, where they had set up training equipment. She came here with Entrapta , and it was also Itel, Rosie and Alatar. Of course, they couldn't forget about Mr. Ilemshaw . She wasn't afraid, however, that the alien living in the aquarium, who was currently steering the ship, might report that she had discovered new properties of her hand. It wasn't such a strange thing to hide it after all. Despite this, she felt strange, as if they were investigating some forbidden secret... Perhaps, that's what they were doing. She wasn't sure what this prosthetic really was, but eventually she had to find out, or at least check what it could do.

Itel looked better in person , though she was still depressed. She guessed it had something to do with what had happened at her sister's wedding. She had almost fallen into her father's hands then, if not for the fact that Lady Ka had underestimated her shooting skills, and the support of Lonnie and Scarlet. Perhaps she had been too harsh on her, but then again, Itel's wound would heal, but she would have to deal with the scars on her soul, because of what she had done, because of the lives she had

taken. But that wasn't all. Itel saw that Rosie was her girlfriend now. That had probably taken away all her hopes of them ever being together. Because of that, she could feel guilty, because they were still best friends, so it was sad to see her suffer because she had broken her heart. She could do something, right? Maybe if she found someone for her, the Elf would be happy again? It shouldn't be that hard! She had great taste, at least when it came to girls, and she was very observant, so she would know at first glance what dark secrets her friend's future love was hiding. It also cannot be denied that she had great social skills, so she would have no problem convincing anyone that Itel was the love of her or his life.

Both itel and Rosie were to be her Sparring Partners, while Alatar and Entrapta were to handle data collection and other scientific nonsense.

"So where do we start?" she said, her voice a little uncertain. Rosie smiled and said with her gloves.

„From what you did back there in the undergrounds... You know, from those hack’n’slash!”

She nodded, a little uncertain, because she really didn't know what to do now. How did she do it? She tried to swing her hand around, but it didn't help, it just looked like she was trying to ward off a whole cloud of Flies. Finally, she took too much of a swing and hit herself in the face, which, considering her hand was made of metal, really hurt.

„It clearly doesn't work...„ Entrapta said, and nodded to her Rubbing her cheek. „Maybe someone has to threaten you? Sometimes it worked with Adora.„ The princess with purple hair continued. She turned to her girlfriend and called.

„Rosie! Hit me! Hard! As only you can!”

Rosie jumped at her words and said.

„But I don't want to hit you! Even if you ask me to! I can hit you during training, but that's all! „ In her eyes she saw a mixture of horror and indignation.

„Okay, but someone has to hit me … OUCH!„ She exclaimed as Entrapta threw a can at her.

„And how did it work?„ The inventor looked at it with sincere interest.

"If you wanted to give me a headache, then yes," she said irritably, then looked back down at her hand.

„ Maybe just reach into your heart and seek that power? „ Rosie said and blushed with embarrassment. She was about to say that it was a rather strange idea, but then, surprising everyone, Itel spoke up.

"That makes sense... You know, that hand is a part of you, much more than any cybernetic prosthetic. You've had it for years, as long as I can remember. Maybe if you focus, I can somehow try to access its hidden capabilities, you know, like those people who can slow down their own heartbeats and such."

She scratched the side of her head with her hand, and thought about it. She had had this hand for five years, most of her life. She had long since gotten used to it, and she couldn’t even remember what it was like to have a biological right hand. She liked it, and she knew it was very useful, although lately she had been starting to fear it. It was growing, and perhaps one day it would consume her whole. But now, perhaps she could use it for good, and maybe even, if they reached an understanding, she could somehow stop it from growing. So she closed her eyes, and focused. She could slow her heartbeat, she could use it instinctively, through conditioning, though it had never been necessary. Maybe this would be similar. She focused on all the muscles in her body, especially the one near where her hand ended. She reached out and tried to touch whatever the limb was made of. She discovered that it wasn’t really solid. She bought

herself, and then her hand took control as if it was made of something liquid. Entrapta jumped when she saw it and began to speak quickly and loudly.

„It's amazing. Your hand uses nanotechnology, but these aren't nanite machines, but as if created from energy, which fuse into mass. In a sense, this hand is an energy creation, pretending to be created from a matter. I'll have to take samples, To examine the chemical composition, but I certainly won't detect anything, although this is what I have to check anyway, whether I can cut it off for you in a moment, just for a moment... „ She pulled a small circular saw out of her hair, and started to approach it, but when she looked at it warningly, she stepped back and said. „Sorry, sometimes I to eager to examine technology.”

It was still interesting information. She closed her eyes once more and focused. Her hand took the shape of a long scythe, just like before. While Rosie and Entrapta had seen it before, it was the first time for Itel and Alatar. The elf widened her eyes and then summoned the moon blade, and looked at it skeptically.

"If you can't make its edges blunt, then I'm a little afraid to fencing with you..." she said cautiously, and smiled friendly... Itel really needs to find her a girlfriend or boyfriend... She looked at the hand for a moment longer, wondering what other shape it could take, then looked at the other hand, the glove, and had a very interesting idea. The hand returned to its original shape again, but then it transformed into long, curved claws. She looked through them, and then for the first time in a very, very long time, she smiled.

„I got them back... I got my claws back! See! I have claws!„ She called out to everyone and jumped up and then dealt a few quick blows with her new hand.

"Your species always has claws, I think, though I don't think they 're always as sharp as Catra's..." Entrapta asked in an uncertain voice, and Alatar explained.

„Eti's other hand... It was declawed, and the metal one had no claws at all...”

„They were important to me, because thanks to them I was always armed, I could always fight... I could defend myself, I could kill anyone who wanted to hurt me. It's hard for you to imagine what it's like, all you have is your own body, and only it can be your weapon.„ she said in a loud voice, walked up to the wall and ran her claw across it. She made a scratch on it... Those claws were really sharp... She smiled to herself again, she knew it was a very unpleasant smile, like the one she saw on Lady Ka, or... It doesn't matter anymore, she's gone... But she had the right to it. Finally, she discovered a way to at least partially reverse what had been done to her. Of course, she could get a cybernetic prosthesis, and she probably will someday, but not yet, because the maimed hand reminds her of what happened to her and what she still has to do. Namely, kill her father.

When they left the Scorpion sanctuary it was already morning. She was surprised to find that this was probably the first temple she had seen on this planet, although it could have been a sanctuary. There were two soldiers on guard, dressed in black uniforms with the scorpion sting symbol. They were human, with a large amount of elven blood, and probably other species as well. As soon as they saw Hordak, they drew their weapons, long halberds with serrated blades, although they did not look as if they had any experience in using them. But then Mikach ... her husband ran out and calmed them down, saying that they were with them on a mission. They looked at the former ruler of the Horde skeptically, and in their eyes she saw rage and hatred. She guessed that they were former soldiers of the Horde... It was interesting that his own people hated him so much, probably even more than the rest of the planet's inhabitants. She herself put on a hood, in this outfit probably no one would guess that she was the lost queen, but she still tried not to draw attention to herself. Her... husband and sister-in-law warned them about what happens at night in the Valley Of Shattered Armor, but they

seemed skeptical. Then they reached a small town, where she had a few vehicles to rent. They did not ask the queen's father for money, but he still gave them a lot of strange coins, with a moon engraving. She looked at one, shuddered when you saw a simplified image of herself on second side. Before they set off on their journey, they decided to stop at a nearby river. She decided that this was a good time to gain the favor of those gods who might be willing to side with her on this quest. She walked out into the middle of the clearing, and began to offer prayers to Sarenrae. Tirin and Ireanis joined her as well, Tonado was less religious, but he also served his Gods, mainly Caliastria and Desna. To her surprise, both her husband and sister-in-law looked at her strangely, as if she had gone mad, but the invader seemed curious, and the android simply ignored her. She noted this in her mind, and then, when she had finished her prayer, she went to Mikach, and asked him.

„,Would you like to go with me... „ she felt strange Today she had, when she talked to him as if she was a young girl who was just courting her beloved. Mikach, He smiled and followed her, his sister winking at him knowingly as he left.

They found themselves by a babbling stream, the waters of which were clear and transparent. She took a twig lying behind her, threw it into the water, and watching it flow away, she asked.

„What was that about you looking at me while I was Praying to Sarenrae ? Don't you respect her here?

Her husband thought for a moment and then replied, then said carefully

„Truth be told, who is Sarenrae … This is the first time I've heard that name. Is he one of those gods that the people of Eridani and Daedalus bow to? Such customs are not practiced here… Most people simply worship the world if they have anyone to worship. I understand that it is different in other regions of the universe?„ He smiled at her, and she smiled back, which he was unable to see because of the mask.

„ It's strange, Most of the Galaxy worships these or other gods, Although all are pious... It's not a matter of faith, Gods exist and Manage their Domains. It's not that they are infallible or omnipotent... they take care of certain aspects of our world. They don't know and don't see everything, if that's what you're afraid of, they're not like Horde Prime, it doesn't mean that they're all good, often quite the opposite... Zon-Kuthon , or Asmodeus are assholes, And there are even worse... But even they are needed, because evil is part of reality...„ she said in a hunch, not expecting such theological arguments from herself . In truth, she wasn't very religious. She made sacrifices to Besmara, and sometimes she was bored to Sarrnrae and Desna, and sometimes to Calistria, when the Anger in her heart burned especially strongly, but apart from that she rarely thought about such matters. She was a pirate, after all, not a priestess, and she made a living by doing things that everyone considered immoral.

„It's a strange place, this your... our Etheria, but why should it be surprising since it has been cut off from the universe for all these Millennia?„ she added at the end.

„But now it's not, and we have to deal with all the evil of the Galaxy.„ Mikach said with a grim face.

"Indeed, you must... We all must..." she said and put her arm around her husband and said.

„Sometimes it's hard for me to think of this place as my home... The last five years have been... difficult... That's not the right word... my life has been hard for you to understand... I've been... Driven by anger, but also for pragmatic reasons. When you lead pirates, you have to provide them with Loot… I often had to raid and plunder the ships of ordinary merchants who had done nothing to me. Some of them were Azlantii, but not all, many were unlucky ones who had the misfortune to come across me. I tried to avoid unnecessary casualties... but... you understand I do not have enough power over my people to control them completely. I have a lot of evil on my conscience... It may be hard for you to understand because you are a good man, but I am no

longer the person you once knew... That you loved. „ She fell silent and felt tears welling up in her eyes. She began to cry... But her husband put his arms around her neck and said.

„Many bad things happened on this planet... Catra... Grand Marshal of Etheria, ...Sister of that girl you brought, She opened the portal. She wasn't sure what the consequences would be, but it was her or did he make you end up where you experienced so much Suffering..... But I forgave her, because she was a victim herself... Of everything that happened here. You think I wouldn't forgive you… I don't even think I have anything to forgive you.” he said and took off her mask, and then kissed her. She hadn't felt this happy in a long time... she remembered... She now hoped that this kiss would last for eternity. Finally, however, they broke away from each other, and she felt herself blushing, as if she were a teenager.

„So... So we're together again! You're mine again, and I'm yours! It's so wonderful.„ He said with tears in his eyes, falling apart as much as she did. The air was much more humid here, so she could stay without a mask for a while longer. She smiled, and threw off her coat. Underneath she had her regular travel clothes, and said.

„We've lost so much time, we should take every opportunity to make up for it, right, my love?”

he smiled and hugged her again, and then they both lay down on her coat…

The worst part of this expedition was over, or so he thought. In essence, he was a pessimist, although if you look at his life, he was very lucky. He had a family, the one who enslaved him was annihilated, and the He had a family, the one who enslaved him was annihilated, and the punishment for his crimes was, in truth, slight. Now he also managed to avoid the fury of the former queen, not to mention escaping the horde of the living dead and

guard machines. Now they only had to investigate some ruins, and what could have gone wrong then? As he had recently learned, a lot. He wasn't sure how the local Wizards guarded their domain, in fact, he knew little about it, although for many years his right hand had been one of the most powerful sorceress on the planet. He had never been interested in magic, he tried to stay as far away from it as possible, and it had often backfired on him. Right now he was the least useful member of their squad… Before he could have taken care of protecting those sorcerers, but now that the former queen and her entourage had appeared… He didn't know where her power came from, but it was strong enough to protect them… So to tell the truth he wasn't really useful here, but then again he didn't have anywhere else to go right now so he could still participate in this endeavor. The voice of the girl in bionic armor snapped him out of his reverie.

„Good morning … so you are the man… the clone who invaded this planet?„ She asked carefully and he nodded.

„Yes, although you probably already know that from your captain's reaction, you heard how she called me... „ He said, trying to hide the irritation in his voice.

„But how exactly did you do it? Are you such a powerful Warrior that you conquered a kingdom by yourself? I've heard of similar stories, for example Aroden, from the lost Golarion, only he eventually became a God... „ She looked at him with those strange eyes without whites. Even in that armor she seemed so tiny... The android approached them and sat down next to her , watching them and smiling all the time. She seemed delighted that she had gone beyond her ruins... She reminded him a bit of his brother, the one against who inherited his name. He sighed before he began to explain

„I was on one of the factory ships that were completely automated, and could produce machines If only they had the raw materials. I was... a bit lost, but I was still in much better shape than my other brothers when they lost contact with hivemind. I was found by the Scorpion King, Scorpia's grandfather ... Princess

Scorpia... According to local law, he was not a true ruler, because the country was to be ruled by his niece, but he rebelled. He expelled her from the capital... Scorpions were different from the rest of the inhabitants of this planet, they did not consider the First Ones as noble progenitors, but as those who conquered them. I remembered that My big brother defeated this species, and so when I mentioned it, he assumed that we could be allies. He swore allegiance to Horde Prime, but even then I did not delude myself that he would keep his promise after it was all over, because He guessed that I was unable to contact my brother. I armed and trained his men, and thus he banished his niece to Brightmoon. The success was so significant that he eventually declared himself king of all Etheria . On the other hand, your captain... the former queen supported the exiled scorpion's niece... And then Shadow Weaver came, and many things changed. She was a master of intrigue and manipulation, she improved the management of the Fright Zone and used the black Garnet... Although at first she did not have full access to it... At that time I did not fully understand what these stones were, I saw in it a source of energy, nothing more. And so then only the king's niece could use its power, not him or his daughters. In the end the king was murdered... And I and Shadow Weaver gained absolute power... That's it... „ he said looking at the girl, At first he doubted that such old events would interest her. However, she listened to him carefully, and nodded during his words, and then said.

„You were a stranger in a strange land... You did pretty well...”

He frowned and said.

„Strange words from young person ... how old are you? Seventeen? Usually, kids who aren't clones like me with downloaded knowledge don't look at the world this way.

„I am an aristocrat from the Azlantii Star Empire, we learn intrigue from early childhood, although I'm not very good at it anyway, because I spent most of my life on Jadehell, where there was no place for such things... where there was no place for such

things... „ she said in a surprisingly sad voice. Heart Gift listened to their conversation with sincere surprise, and this strange sorcerer and the king-consort's sister were sitting next to each other, and Saihe was telling her something, but Castaspella seemed not to be too happy about it, and massaged her temples, and this little creature seemed to be patrolling the clearing, which with its short legs required some work from it.

At that moment the queen returned with her husband. Something had changed, though he wasn't sure what. Castaspella bared her teeth in a smile... What was she so happy about? But then the queen looked at him and, frowning, said menacingly.

„I hope this individual didn't bother you?”

„No, Madam Captain, I wanted to ask him about some things... „ said the girl, a little embarrassed, and he added.

„I only gave her a short lesson in history and politics, but I have the impression that when it comes to the latter, I am the one who could learn from her.”

The next tests consisted of using Eti's hand to throw energy bolts, which probably surprised Dragonkin the most , probably because he had never suspected that hand of such properties. In Rosie's opinion, it was very interesting and useful, after all, she had already used it once to shoot down a Drone. The targets were holographic Gremlins floating in the air, moving erratically in front of a solid wall of self-regenerating material. The first shots were not very accurate, it took Eti some time to develop the technique. She was concerned that with each shot, the cat girl grimaced, and her hair stuck out more and more.

„Okay, and I have another such idea. „ Eti said and pulled out the battery, took it in her hand, which sucked all the power out of it and then fired a powerful beam of energy. It pierced the wall, making a hole in it, and the cat-like girl was thrown back. She

could smell hot metal, and burning. Terrified, she ran to her girlfriend and took her in her arms, checking if she was okay Eti's hair was sticking out in all directions, and her metal hand lay limp, but she was relieved to find that nothing serious had happened to her. She sighed heavily, and wiped her forehead from the sweat that had covered it. Entrapta approached her, clearly used to such sights, which was a bit worrying, but Alatar seemed to be worried.

„I guess it's better to use it only as a last resort... „ Dragonkin said quietly and seemed to be scanning her with his cybernetic eye.

„Like when you don't cook the steak again... I don't like it rare, I'm not a cat to eat raw meat!„ the cat girl grumbled, which from what she knew meant she was in good shape...

„Your body is not yet fully adapted to conduct such an amount of energy... If you were made entirely of this Nano energy material... „ Entrapta said, but Eti shuddered. The princess inventor did not know what was happening to Eti's body. She probably did not mean anything bad by it, I guess , but it revived the girl's old peace.

„I think I need to rest a bit... „ said Eti and went to her cabin.

Rosie was very nervous. This was going to be a very important moment for her… And everything had to be perfect. She was wearing a bathrobe that she had brought with her at the very beginning of the journey, but somehow she had never put it on, there was no occasion, but now it would come in very handy. She knocked on the door of Her girlfriend's cabin and heard from inside.

„Come in, I probably won't bite, but I'm not promising anything.„ Eti said. She took a deep breath and went inside. Her girlfriend was wearing only shorts and a blouse with sleeves, so she was much more lightly dressed, you see usually. That's actually good...

„Oh hi Rosie… „ She said almost smiling. She smiled back, she had her glasses but preferred not to take gloves because of what she was about to do.

„I wanted... I wanted... I mean... „ she tried to speak in sign language, but it wasn't easy at the moment.

„Yes? Is something wrong? Eti asked , tilting her head to the side. In her eyes she saw anxiety and concern. She took a deep breath and let the ties of her robe fall to the floor... She had nothing underneath... At the sight of her nakedness, the girl's jaw dropped... She blinked a few times and said.

„ Rosie... What are you... „ she was completely astonished and probably shocked. She felt herself turning red with shame. She was so stupid, she made an idiot of herself! The stupidest girl in the entire Galaxy. She knelt down and reached for her bathrobe. She was so ashamed... Tears ran down her face. But then she felt a hand on her right shoulder. A hand without a glove. She looked up and saw Eti, who was smiling at her shyly, she seemed to be as embarrassed as she was. She helped her up and asked.

„That means... That you want to be with me... „ Eti wasn't sure where to look.

„Make love to you? Well, yes... you've already done what, you've told me about it and on top of that, what I've seen... „ She said again feeling herself blush.

„Okay then... If you're sure... „ said the cat girl and she nodded, and then her girlfriend wrapped her tail around her waist, put one hand on her chest, and hugged her with the other and kissed her.

Chapter End Notes

Here's the next chapter! I'm asking for your suggestions and opinions.

Castaways from the Sea of Stars - Part One

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

„I don't like riding horses, it hurts me all over... Especially my butt, but also my head. A little longer and my brain turned to jelly, I tell you. „ Rao cried out loudly and ostentatiously to attract Klest's attention.. To emphasize the importance of their words, they swayed on his mount's back, as if they was about to fall.

„That's great„ said the woman with blood-colored hair, not even looking in his direction. Miriam, on the other hand, gave him a look full of irritation, but then grimaced and leaned over the back of her horse. They sighed seeing their friend's suffering. In reality, horseback riding didn't bother them, although it wasn't used to it, but they wanted to somehow suggest to Klest that she slow down, because they knew that Miriam was suffering a lot. Unfortunately, their friend was very ashamed to admit that she was suffering. It was caused by her leg. They knew that the dark spell cast by the Royal Mage to encourage the other rulers to war caused her to be crippled. Since then, pain had been constantly with her. For her this ride must have been real torture, but the woman with cold, dead eyes didn't care. They were furious with her, but they also couldn't do much, because this woman was not entirely balanced and they preferred not to provoke her. Only if it goes on like this, Miriam will drop from exhaustion, And they won't survive this! Unfortunately, their friend didn't want to complain, although her words might have somehow influenced Klest period.

They rode together in a whole caravan of horses. Most of the members of their group looked like bandits or mercenaries employed by Klest, although some made a slightly better impression, and seemed to be scholars, who for some reason

were with a woman who looked like she dyed her hair in the blood of her victims. Maybe she did, they couldn't see it, but they didn't want to rule it out. Ghost rode next to them, lost in thought, and paying more attention to her companions.

At first, after the Huntsman had been chased away, they had been driving for a good two hours, they kept seeing this huge cloud of smoke, which was supposed to come from where Miriam had gone with Klest. Every now and then, the woman with blood-red hair would take out some small device, point it at the cloud and check something while looking at it, and then she heard herself drive on with relief. It must have been an exaggeration, that the cloud looked a bit like a big mushroom…

They met the rest of Klest's subordinates at the nearest bridge, where they were waiting for them, apparently against orders, because the woman with red hair became irritated and she yelled at a pair of elves..

„What are you doing here! I told you to get the hell to the fortress, And you're waiting here for devils knows why!”

The moon elves paid little attention to their employer's outburst of anger, but the woman said.

“It would be better if we waited until you did, because without you there's no point in talking to Buri and Iron Hand anyway..”

„But now if someone chases us, they will head straight for that bridge, because it is the easiest way to cross the entire river within a radius of many kilometers.„ Klest continued to yeling.

„But why would someone be chasing us?„ asked the Partner… Or maybe the Elf's brother.

„That's why! „ She pointed at a huge cloud of smoke in shape of mushroom rising nearby. That was probably enough of an explanation, because they both nodded and without further questions they set off on their journey. They rode for another day, and they didn't even slow down for the night, until finally the sky

on the horizon began to take on the red color of dawn. It was not certain how far they had traveled, and the group had no wagons, and they carried all their supplies on mules and other more exotic animals. Actually, they could admire their organization, at first glance Klest didn't look like anyone, but she was able to impose any discipline on anyone, including herself. They even seemed to treat their leader with respect bordering on adoration, which was completely their beyond understanding.

On the way Miriam told him what had happened. They were almost excited, when they heard that their friend was on board the Star Boat, and were downright jealous, and then they werelearned that this explosion came from the destroyed star boat.. It clutched its head when it learned what the woman with red hair had done to that ship! How could something destroy such a magnificent ancient object! But oh well, that woman looked like someone who would have no problem burning a last book on the world just to keep warm.

Neither knew who Jaso was working with, except that they were extremely dangerous individuals. Even Khandros was afraid of them, and he was terrible individual knew that far too well. They guessed who they might be, they had heard about them from Prospero… People who worship the Dark Beings of legend, and not only humans but also his kin, supposedly their rulers did not care what race their servants belonged to. But what could they do? They were only a scholar, A not-so-resourceful person who once wanted to get to know the world, but then painfully experienced its dark side and was brutally brought down to earth in a very literal way… Now they only wanted… They were not sure what they wanted from life… They only knew that they wanted to be with Miriam and wanted to help her… at all costs….

They pressed its lips together and pulled on the stirrups, stopping their mount. The animal stopped in place, and almost fell because of it, only its unusual sense of balance saved it from falling.

“We have to stop!” they called, and then everyone was moving toward them, and for a moment it felt like it was going to panic,

but with a great effort it controlled itself and called again.

„She needs to rest!„ it pointed at Miriam, who turned all red and growled angrily.

„I can speak for myself!”

They looked at her friend and said.

„Well, tell them, instead of dying from pain. You're in such a state that tomorrow you won't be able to get out of bed, and what will happen then?„ They shouted, trying to sound like someone confident.

„I'll manage somehow, it's none of your business.„ the Queen's Cousin grawled. Klest, who was opposite the column, uttered a few loud curses, then turned around and when she reached them, she said

"Maybe, for fuck's sake , you could save your lovers' quarrel for another time, because I'd be in a hell of a hurry?" Her eyes glowed a strange blue.

„We're not... What's it to you anyway! You're dragging us to some fortress, but you don't deign to explain why and what you intend to do there! We don't know who you are or what you're up to! We do know that you have many enemies, and one of them is so terrible that you'd rather tire these mounts than slow us down so that we could think about what we're planning, and where we're actually going ... And yes, Rao is right, my leg hurts in a way that's impossible to describe.”

Klest looked at her grimly and spoke slowly with a humorless smile on her face.

„When you agreed to participate in this expedition, you didn't ask for details and now you've changed your mind? I guess it's a bit too late for that...”

Miriam gave her an equally gloomy look and said gloomily.

„You promised us to explain in the future, so now is actually a good time, because seriously, now is the perfect time. „ For a moment, both women stared at each other and finally Klest said.

„Lord Tholuvian is one of the avatars of the Unnamed Darkness, something incredibly powerful and, more importantly, absolutely terrifying… Your elven friend probably knows who we're talking about…

They knew... They had heard tales, not only those known to his people, but also those told by lonely scholars like Prospero, and hermits gazing in horror at the starry sky... They had read fragments of ancient books, the original versions of which they had fortunately never seen... until recently. And they recognized the name... The Unnamed Darkness, the Nameless Mist, and the Creeping Chaos... Three ancient beings, so old that They were already ancient when the first stars lit up. They were not certain whether she was exactly... or he... They? They could not even define that, if it was possible at all. Miriam noticed their expression, frowned, and then asked.

„And what does that mean? Some guy with a pretentious title is going to chase you, but looking at you, it doesn't seem to me that this is new to you. Anyway, it seems to me that with these people, and with your skills, you should probably manage... The three of us managed his servant, now it shouldn't be any harder.

Klest looked at her for a moment and then she started laughing nervously, which her subordinates didn't pay much attention to, they just went about their business.

„You know nothing about the secrets that this universe holds, and pray to all your gods that you don't get to know them up close like I did. Although from what I've noticed, it's too late for you and this world. I had met him once before, a long, long time ago, when my mother had struck a deal with him and wanted to sacrifice me to him to kill my father..... and he probably hasn't forgotten that. believe me, I saw his face and the horror hidden there… I would sooner set Xadia on fire than let myself be

captured... But okay, we still have to rest for a few hours, because I have to check a few things I've learned. Tell your loved one that you can relax. At least for two hours... I hope that's enough for you.„ The woman said, smiling slyly, and then she started giving orders to the rest of her subordinates.

„But you didn't tell us where we were going?„ said Miriam, not taking her eyes off the woman with red hair.

„To my friends, that should be enough for now.„ Klest said, smiling venomously, as always.

„What do you mean when you say friends? Do you mean people from... the same place as you?”

This time Klest smiled differently than usual. This time the smile was sad, even nostalgic.

“Oh no. There is no one left, that would be from where I was born.„ she said quietly, and and now for the first time Rao saw a human being in her, sad and overwhelmed by what she had experienced..

They didn't have much time to rest, so Miriam decided she could sit down and make some tea and see if they had anything for a snack. She wasn't really hungry, and she would gladly drink something very strong that would ease the pain. Herbs didn't work on her condition, or at least she didn't know of any. It was possible that somewhere in Xadia there was a healer who could help her cope with what had been done to her, but she was starting to lose hope... Perhaps what Klest had said was true, and somewhere out there among the stars there lived someone who could help her. But the pain was only a small part of her suffering. Now she felt something like hunger, as if she had to satisfy a need she couldn't name, although she knew what she had to do. She could hold out for a while, but she wasn't sure how long. Was the desire to find a cure for her condition the main reason she stuck

with this woman? Probably. Of course, she didn't hide the fact that she also wanted to learn more about what stretched beyond the vault of heaven. It was hard for her to imagine that anything could exist outside the continent she knew. Even the tales of the distant southern islands seemed quite fantastic. And the fact that there were other worlds, inhabited by completely alien ores, was hard to grasp even for someone like her. Just a few years ago, even the other side of the continent seemed inaccessible. And now she was traveling with a Skywing Elf scholar, a Moonshadow Elf Illusionist, and a woman who claimed to have come from the stars.. She should feel full of hope because new possibilities were opening up before her, which she could once only dream of. But now she felt only pain, exhaustion and apathy... So now she looked at the boiling tea, silent and gloomy, until Rao sat down next to her.

"I know... I probably shouldn't ask how you're feeling, right?" They said carefully, but it was watching her with concern. She smiled at him, still in pain, and reached out to take his hand in hers, and said.

„I'm sorry for what I said. You wanted to help me, and I was mean to you . You have a good heart and you really care about others, even me, even though I'm not a good person."

Rao looked at her in astonishment, and cried out.

„What are you talking about! You're the best person I've ever been!„ They squeezed her hand tighter.

„I am a dark mage, someone with the ability to do terrible things in the name of power and might. No dark mage is innocent, the soul of each of us has been marked by darkness. There is not an ounce of nobility in us, despite what he tries to convince others. Viren may have been able to wash his face with the good of humanity and the safety of Xadia, but I am not like him. For me, all dark mages would die ... Including me. „ she said and looked down... A single tear ran down her cheek, and then Rao hugged her and wiped her face.

„Don't say such things! You're wonderful... You're wonderful... You're...„ Rao started crying and hugging her.

„Will you do something for me?„ she asked quietly. Rao nodded, because he knew what she was asking of him. He moved closer and then she embraced him. Their lips touched. From the outside it looked like a kiss, but it wasn't. She took a breath, and began to suck the air out of Rao's lungs. The elven person arched back as if in ecstasy. But they also began to suffocate. She too felt a surge of pleasure, because she had devoured his life force. Her body was filled with sudden power... She wanted more... She began to take his life force once again. More and more ... Rao's body became cold and hard as a stone. They were on the sidelines and no one paid attention to them, thinking that it was just an ordinary kiss. She wanted to stop, but she couldn't. With horror, she realized that she was about to kill Rao ... Finally, someone pulled her back and she tore herself away from the sky elf.

„What are you doing to them? You were killing them!„ said the Ghost in a sharp voice.

„I'm sorry... I didn't mean to.„ she cried and wanted to run to Rao , but the Moonshadow Elf grabbed her by the arm and pulled her away again. She went to Rao herself and looked at him. When she felt his pulse, she said.

„Fortunately they are alive, but it was lucky. What did you do to it? I've only heard of such things in legends."

„ I… I…. Sometimes I have to do this because… I'm cursed… When Viren cast the spell, I was pretending to be my cousin… They must have been mistaken… I survived, but I was maimed… What's worse, I'm slowly dying… Or rather, I'm becoming a living corpse… a monster from dark stories…„ she lowered her head, because that was the truest truth. She was a monster. She almost killed one of the few people who cared about her. She should have died during the attack then… Why the hell did she have such a strong will to live. Then she felt a hand on her shoulder. She

looked up and saw Rao looking at her with sadness and concern in his eyes.

„I'm so sorry... I'm sorry!„ she cried through tears, but the Elven person sat down next to her and hugged her.

„It's nothing... Nothing happened... You see, nothing is wrong with me... I just need to eat properly... Do you think they have a good cook in this Hammerhall ?„ They asked, smiling broadly...

The fortress of Hammerhal looked impressive, and even by human standards, at least according to Gwendolyn. Her people did not build castles, or even cities, but lived in large semi-self-sufficient villages that protected themselves with the help of illusion magic and the blades of their warriors. This fortress was built on the shape of a star, its storms were not the tallest, but thick and full of cannons. She had heard of this human invention, still quite new and somewhat unwieldy, but capable of causing terrible destruction. From what she had heard, the fortress was an extraordinary construction, and built with the money of its owner. Supposedly, he had found large deposits of silver on the border of the kingdom and the elven lands, which he invested in smelters of excellent quality steel and a glassworks, so strong and transparent, that could not be obtained anywhere else. Then, when he was already rich, he bought a lot of Earth from a debt-ridden noble house living on the border. Few were willing to live so close to Xadia, where a single Angry Dragon could devastate the entire area and destroy your life's work. Now, of course, the situation had changed dramatically, Xadia had opened up to travelers from outside, and many large towns had sprung up near the passage, although she did not know how much the lord of this fortress benefited from their existence, but as far as she knew human enterprise, he had certainly grown rich from it.

The fortress stood on a hill, around which a small town had grown. Further on stretched green fields, where grain and fruit trees grew. Here, near the breach, the land was fertile, maybe not

as fertile as borderlandss in Duren , but those who were brave enough to settle here could reap truly magnificent harvests. However, many people were still too afraid to live near the border of the country of bloodsuckers and murderers. Although the young king tried to convince his subjects that these were just made-up Tales, She knew well that there was more to them than just a Grain of Truth... She looked at Miriam riding next to her, who looked much more rested. Unfortunately, there were many more dark Legends in the world than she could have guessed.

She kept to the back and watched everyone carefully. Her greatest attention was of course drawn by the leader of their not-so-small Caravan. Earlier, due to her profession, she had heard a bit about this woman, although she had never personally provided her with any services. She knew that she was a treasure hunter and a surprisingly educated person considering her appearance as a murderer and bandit. Now, however, she learned that she was hiding much more, and she really wanted to find out what. It caused a gigantic explosion that caused the sun to be temporarily obscured by a cloud of dust.. The Dark Mage felt insecure around her, and then some monster came for her and her companions, whom she had not heard of even in the most terrifying stories. What connections could she possibly have with the owner of this fortress, supposedly one of the richest people in the entire kingdom? She did not know, but it was only a matter of time before she found out.

When they stood at the fortress wall, Klest went to the gate and called out.

„Tell old Brumi to get off his ass and let me in because his buddy has a lot to talk about... What the fuck are you doing? I have to fucking write this, I can do it with a knife if you keep pissing me off!„ She shouted and shook her fist at the two guards who were watching her with their jaws hanging open. Seeing that they were not reacting to her words, Klest took out a knife and started sharpening her nails with it ostentatiously, until they finally came to their senses and ran downstairs. After a moment, the gate opened and their whole group drove inside.

She had never been without any human fortress, but this one looked strange somehow... In addition to a large number of cannons, all the guards were armed with menacing-looking muskets with strange locks, inside there was a statue of a man with a long beard and an axe in his hands. She suspected that it was the lord of the castle, but then she saw him when he went downstairs.

He was a short man, she knew that happened to humans. But unlike other similar cases, his proportions were completely different, he was also powerfully muscled and his ears were slightly pointed.

„Tell me you're not bothering me out of boredom, for fuck's sake, or Celinka will greet you.„ He pointed to the large hammer he carried on his back.

"I'd sooner blow your stupid head off, but I just came on an important matter. I found it! I found the other ship!" she cried and started laughing. The man's eyes widened and he bared his teeth.

„Really? That's great! I'll call the others right away! feel good here, I've settled in well, but Iron Hand, Shash, and Iath will be happy. Too bad Damien didn't live to see it. „ He said, smiling sadly. She knew the name, it was the name of the Royal Mage Calum first father, but it couldn't have come from him, could it? She didn't know much about him, but he probably wasn't someone who would hang out with people like Klest...

„And what about Scyilis?„ asked the woman with murderous eyes, and she had a feeling she saw Concern on her face.

„Everything is fine with your sister, as good as it can be. fine in her case. Nothing terrible has happened since the last time, so I guess it's fine, right?„ he said, he said that I would be embarrassed.

„Good, Call everyone to gather in the chamber of secrets... „ The woman with scarlet hair gave the order. „ Then she pointed

behind her and said. „ These are Miriam, Queen Aanya's cousin, and Rao, an elven scholar.„ She pointed to the pair behind her. The dark bag nodded, looking uncertainly at the Host, but Rao walked up to him and grabbed his hand, then said.

„Oh, it's nice to meet you. I've never been to a fortress like this and I've always been curious about what they look like inside.”

The short man shook his head disapprovingly, but sighed heavily and introduced himself.

„You can call me Brumi Hammerhall From the Hammerhall Clan . And by the way, I'm a dwarf, but that probably means nothing to you anyway so let's get to the point.” he gestured for them to leave.

"What about me?" the Ghost asked cautiously, and everyone looked her way as if she had been essentially invisible up until now, like the Ghost.

„I think you should stay here, because I don't know how much I can trust you... Someone will probably assign you quarters soon, right?„ Klest said, smiling slyly at her.

„Of course, it's not a problem for me, and I'm so tired, comma, I'd love to rest.„ she replied, smiling much more friendly, but in her mind she was already planning how to get inside. After all, she was a snake, and these can squeeze into any crack

Chapter End Notes

Here's another chapter. I hope I didn't mix up Rao's pronouns. Feel free to comment

Castaways From The Sea Of Stars. – Part Two

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

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She felt disoriented as she followed Klest and her friend. Of course, if the woman could have someone like that as a friend, she wasn't sure. However, their relationship seemed quite friendly, which was something she had never expected. She had heard a little about the ruler of Hammerhall Fortress, but no about secrets like these. At times he inspired the admiration or envy of the Duren nobility, and was a living proof of Katolian determination.. Now, of course, he aroused much more interest in himself, because they were right next to the border that had just been opened. She had to admit that she intended to go to this area anyway, when she wanted to travel on the other side of the continent. Of course, after what had happened to her, rumors about foreign Lords were of little interest to her, unless they were related to the cursed by the gods Mage. She wondered why someone with such a good reputation would hang out with someone who was an adventurer and a murderer.. On the other hand, many aristocrats secretly associated with underworld types in order to look after the interests of their family.. But Klest was no ordinary adventurer. Like this man, she came here from outside their world, which went some way to explaining where he got his fortune, at least in part... But she was more worried about what they would do with her. She didn't trust Klest any more than she did the hungry and angry Bantera, and besides, even if she had promised her something, it was not certain that her friends would honor her promises. On the other hand, these Brumi seem like a man who kept his word, and would not poison his guests. But she knew that appearances could be deceiving, after all, that was what politics was all about. She could only hope that Brumii would

guess that his acquaintance with the queen's cousin would help him much more than it would hurt him.

She realized that they were going deeper and deeper down, towards the underground part of the fortress. That Chamber of Secrets was probably there. She had to admit that the less sensible part of her was glad that they would learn secrets that she had not even dreamed of a few days ago. She had to be careful, because it was easy to lose vigilance when you were so close to satisfying your desires. That was why she kept telling herself that she had to keep an eye on everything and be the more sensible of the two. Rao, however, seemed completely charmed and happy with where they had ended up.

„Oh, that's a really magnificent structure, I've never been that deep underground, maybe apart from the brewery. I almost fell into a beer barrel there, because I was curious how deep it was. I didn't even know you could build barrels that big! To this day I don't know how many people would have to drink all the beer they stored there!”

Brumi laughed heartily and said.

„All it takes is one modest dwarven party, and I assure you, there is no barrel in the galaxy that hasn't been emptied by thirsty dwarves!„ Their host assured them, and added after a moment of thought. „It must be admitted, however, that the beer here is not that bad, in Katolis they know what they're doing, although of course their beer cannot be compared to true Dwaven Ale.”

„You've already used that word... Is that what the inhabitants of your kingdom are called? Where is it? Are you a person from the stars like Klest?„ Rao showered him with petals , clearly pleased that they could expand their knowledge. She also listened attentively to their conversation, but did not speak. Brumi laughed and said.

„That's a lot of questions at once! I like you already! And no, the name dwarf has nothing to do with any kingdom, it's the name of

my species... Supposedly we come from the Lost Golarion, where we once had a few kingdoms, but that's ancient times, and now we live scattered throughout the galaxy. Many of us mine asteroids and comets. We have a lot of small kingdoms, usually consisting of a single stronghold, where a king or thane rules ...”

„Oh, so you're the king here too!„ Rao interrupted him. Their eyes shone with fascination.

Brumi waved his hand and said with a laugh.

„There must be many more dwarves living here than just me, and the king would probably be a little nervous if someone declared himself king on his lands... Even this nice kid.„ then he raised an eyebrow. „You didn't ask what comets, Golarion and the like are, but the most important thing for you right now. You're quite smart, and you think outside the box, I like you!„ he patted Rao firmly on the back, Which blushed and said.

„Oh That was very nice! But I have one more question! Are you preparing a nice dinner? Because I ate there once yesterday, and I'm very hungry!”

This time the lord of the castle laughed loudly and said.

„Don't worry, I don't skimp on cooks, And besides, I have some specialties here according to ancient dwarven recipes. My friends can cook too!”

„If Iron Hand keeps serving what it used to, it could be fun if an elven kid tries to eat it.„ Klest said, baring her teeth, sho she gave her an irritated look. She had never understood the contemptuous or hostile attitude towards elves.

„Don't worry! I never actually add battery fluid to soup anymore... ehh, I remembered how Damien broke his tooth because Anacite served a whole dead ground turtle for dinner.„ He sighed, smiling , Although she saw sadness in his eyes. She looked at them sideways. She knew that this and where Prince Calum's biological father, now a Royal High Mage, also wore... Of course, it could be

a coincidence, the case used to live in an inn run by sisters Aanya and Miriam, so she should have suspected nothing... But after what she had recently learned, she considered that anything was possible.

Finally they came to a large czamber, higher than the outer wals of the fortress. Beyond the door were several levels of galleries, from one of which led to a post that connected with what was stored here.

It was a triangular metal object, as big as a house, maybe even bigger. It stood on three supports, and she had the impression that it had something like a cannon or a huge musket mounted in front, and something similar at the top, two narrow barrels set in a semicircular dome…... As soon as she saw it, she stopped and stared open-mouthed, and Rao folded his hands in delight.

„Oh this thing is wonderful! Truly fascinating!! I don't know what it is, but it's beautiful!”

Rao exclaimed happily and Klest asked.

„How did you get him here? That must have taken a hell of a lot of work.

„It wasn't hard, because Iron Hand fixed the drive a bit, enough for us to rise up and we flew into this cave and then I built a fortress over it.. It took some time, and it cost a lot of gold. We hit rocks a few times trying to fit in here, but it was just scratches. Compared to what that bastard did to him, it was nothing serious...” He pointed to the cracks in the armor stretching across the starboard side of the ship. You could see through two more layers of plating.

„This is your.. spaceship, right?„ she asked, not even looking at the other hosts. Brumi nodded thoughtfully and said slowly with a bit of sadness in his voice

„ This is the Sailor of Far Horizon, our ship that brought us here. Unfortunately, it was badly damaged and well, we're trapped here

unless our dear Klest has come up with something.”

„Perhaps, but it will require your help.„ The woman with the blue eyes of a murderer said, smiling mysteriously.

She looked again at the cracks in the hull, which looked a bit like grays . She had the impression that they resembled, disturbingly, claw marks…

"What damaged it?" she asked cautiously, feeling a strange, indefinable unease. She didn't know anything about spaceships, but they had to be incredibly resilient... They had to survive Starstorms or something, right? It must have been terribly windy this high above the highest mountains that made sense, after all, that was how the sun moved, right?

„We had an encounter with a Void Dragon... A particularly lousy beast... „ The dwarf spat to the side. Rao's eyes widened in delight upon hearing this.

„Oh, you really met a real Void Dragon here! This is incredible! I've read about this creature in books and heard many legends about it!„ They said with excitement. Then another person appeared on the gallery. She was tall and had long silver-blue hair , a little androgynous facial features and she was dressed in trousers and a jacket. at her belt she had a pistol, looking even stranger than the one Klest had. Her eyes were the same color, Pink, with no visible whites, and her ears were pointed, like an elf's. But she was hornless and had five fingers.

„ Oh I see you've changed a bit Iath ... You're a she/her now, aren't you?„ Klest asked, tilting her head to the side.

„And you haven't changed at all Which is surprising considering that over 20 years have passed. Even I felt all the years that had passed since we were trapped here.„ The woman said, crossing her arms over her chest.

„You see, I lead a healthy lifestyle. I eat few carbs, spend a lot of time outdoors , and have a glass of wine every day! Just like the

nutritionists say!„ Said a woman with cold Blue eyes that showed no Joy, despite the smile on her face. Then the woman called Iath looked at them and raised an eyebrow.

„I see you've brought some guests with you... That's nice, because I've been bored hanging out here for a while now, and I'm careful not to draw attention, because someone might wonder who this strange Elf is... „ She said, smiling at them a little warmer than Klest 's. Rao sucked in a breath with a hiss , and asked excitedly.

„You're a half-elf, aren't you? I've been wondering for some time whether you really exist! Because for many years... There's never been a mixed human-elf couple!”

"Why did you think about it?" she suddenly interjected with a hint of suspicion, and Rao's face reddened. Klest rolled her eyes and said.

„So maybe I'll introduce you to the rest and we can talk about our affairs?”

They were quite hungry, although they demanded a tasty meal mainly because they wanted to show Miriam in this way that what had happened didn't bother it at all. It was probably their first time...it mean, it wasn't the first time she had fed on them... They had had to help her a few times when she was particularly exhausted, especially after using magic. They had heard that once she had paid... various people to take Their breath... However, it was risky, because in this way someone could find out what was happening to her. Even in Duren, Dark magic was not forbidden, but something like that could arouse fear and hatred in many of the inhabitants of this kingdom. That is why they offered to help their... friend in this regard. It wasn't at all about the fact that it was almost like a kiss, although it didn't bother them at all... This time, however, it was different than usual, and they felt like they were dying, they were turning into stone... It was a terrible

feeling, but they had already experienced much worse things in their life, so they decided not to burden they friend with guilt. Especially since there were fascinating discoveries waiting for them. These people confirmed That they came from the Sea Of Stars, They saw their boat, that's a ship and it was beautiful! And they met a void dragon. That was also amazing, because these were creatures from legends that inspired fear but also delight. A part of their soul wanted him to meet one of these creatures themselves, although they knew that it would be a truly terrifying encounter. However, if they wanted to know the world, they had to be ready to encounter its darkest side. And then there was that Half-Elf! Very few stories survived, and most of them were rather unreliable, about whether children could be created from mixed unions of their races... In fact, they expected that it should have more Horns and fewer Fingers, But it still gave him hope for... Why did he think about such nonsense?

They were ushered into a large hall, with a long stone table made of centers. Here, so close to the ship, they didn't see many servants, but everything was so clean that someone must have been cleaning it. From the next room, he could smell freshly prepared food.

„Shash has already started preparing the meal, for I sent a messenger as soon as I saw you. I have a few trusted servants here, though even Oli does not know everything about us, apart from Shash's wife.„ Brumi said, making Klest whistle.

„You surprised me with that... For an honorable and brave Vesk to lose his head for a human... It's impossible to understand.„ She said smiling, but Iath , who sat down next to Brumi, said.

„A lot of things have happened here during your absence , although you probably won't consider much of it important. You've only been here once every year or two, just for money and ammunition... We had to live here somehow, while you were playing treasure hunter, like in the old stories.„ She said and put her hand on Brumi's shoulder .

„I see...„ Said the woman with blood-colored hair gloomily.„As you can see, I've been busy looking for a way to get us out of here, and also to get the information we came here for. I've created my own company of adventurers and made many alliances to do that, just look at these two.„ She said and introduced them in two words. Iath. The other woman raised her head to the side, and looked at Rao with curiosity, a bit like he was an exotic pet and asked.

„That's interesting, it's the first time I've seen an elf here, not counting Klest's two friends, but I couldn't see them properly, which I regret very much.„ She said and winked at the Dwarf, he looked at her reproachfully. They blushed again at her words, and then Iath continued.

"I've never seen anyone like you before ... Let me remind you, are you a Sky Elf or a Star Elf?" she said and pulled out a rectangular silver object and started tracing and tapping it with her finger.

„Well, I'm a skywing elf... Don't you recognize us? Even humans rarely have trouble with that, and you're, well... half one of us! Well, half-elf!„ They called in confusion. The woman narrowed her eyes and spoke slowly.

„If you said that somewhere on the elven continent of Castroval, you would get punched in the face and lose all your teeth!"

Tye wanted to ask why that would happen… But then dinner was brought inside.. A stout woman came out from the next room , followed by two young servants… If the tureen with the delicious-smelling soup, as well as the plates.

„You're lucky I got caught up in something today, and I suspected you'd have some guests, or we'd have dinner together, so I prepared more in advance... And good morning to our wonderful guests, I hope you like it... „ She smiled at them, and Rao smiled back and greeted them.

„Oh, I'm so glad you made more because I'm terribly hungry!„ and started eating the soup. It was good, paprika-tomato with meat, with small pasta, slightly spicy. The woman patted her on the head and said.

„They fought with us for so many years, and because of that no one knew how polite they are.”

Miriam also began to eat, but watched the hosts closely. They wanted to tell her not to worry, but it probably wouldn't have helped anyway. After a while, a new person entered, and when it saw him, it almost choked on its meal. At first, they mistook him for a small, two-legged Dragon, but then they realized that it was a large lizard... It was huge, covered in hard blue-green scales. It had long claws and lots of sharp teeth. At first, they wanted to hide under the table, but then they thought of Miriam, and moved closer to her, to cover her if necessary. The queen's cousin smiled at them, but seemed not to be afraid of the Newcomer.

„This is Shash. Zerkuroz of Veskarium.„ Brumi introduced him. The lizard smiled, showing a multitude of sharp teeth.

„I welcome the honorable guests and guarantee your safety with my honor.„ he said in a solemn tone. His voice was surprisingly pleasant and melodic, they could hear traces of a foreign accent in it.

„Veska... What? „ Rao asked in confusion, and then they heard a strange scratching and knocking sound behind him , and after a moment a strange metallic voice spoke from that direction.

„The Veskarium is a powerful interplanetary Empire dominated mainly by a species called the Vesks, a very warlike but also extremely honorable reptilian species.

They turned slowly and saw this! It looked like a metal spider with many legs, but it was huge, larger than a human. Most of the limbs ended in grasping hands, and in the center of the egg-shaped body was a hemisphere that had a dozen eyes. Seeing this

creature, they jumped onto the table, and grabbed a spoon, ready to fight in defense of Miriam, who must have been a little scared too, because she grabbed her staff and reached into her Magical Ingredients Bag.

„This is Iron Hands, He is Anacite of Abbalon. An intelligent machine created by a certain ancient civilization.„ Iath explained .

„I'm not sure if the word ancient is appropriate here, as it usually implies that the civilization is extinct, and that's not what happened here. That's one of the reasons we're here in the first place.„ The being said, and Miriam frowned.

„Why did you come here, actually? I don't know much about the Sea Of Stars, but I guess the journey through them isn't all that easy, and I'm not sure what you could possibly want from us „ Dark Mage asked with suspicion in her voice.

„That's a good question, and I think we need to explain it to you... Sit comfortably, and listen.„ Iath said in a calm voice, and Rao sat down in the chair, barely containing their excitement.

Gwendolyn was polite at first and went with everyone to the guest rooms where they were to rest and eat. She was exhausted, although not as exhausted as the queen's cousin, but she couldn't afford to rest. She used illusion magic and made it seem like she was lying on a bed, then cast an indetection spell. It was harder than taking on the appearance of someone else, but still much easier than invisibility. Above all, it required great caution, so that no one would get too close or suspect that someone was nearby. Fortunately, the path her companions were taking was not guarded by guards, and they themselves did not seem to suspect that someone might be following them. She just had to keep a certain distance, so as not to get too close, and at the same time be able to hear what they were saying, which was not so difficult, because Miriam had to lean on a cane, and she was the most exhausted of them all, so everyone had to adjust their pace to

her. Soon they reached a large hall, in the middle of which was a large metal object. Then she saw the strange woman. She looked unusually for an elf, and she had too few horns and too many fingers. Rao was delighted with their new acquaintance, but Miriam looked suspicious. That didn't surprise her... She had heard a lot about how the Duren court was rife with intrigue, and that anyone who stayed there had to learn to deal with conspiracies and lies. She had developed such skills, not only because she was an Illusionist, but also because of who she served. The Serpent's Path demanded cunning and ruthlessness from its members... and fanatical devotion.

As they moved on, she followed them and still managed to remain undetected. They entered the dining room, she decided to stay outside and listen to what they were saying... She learned that another person had joined the meal, whose appearance greatly disturbed the gathered, but that was not what she should worry about, because a terrible creature walked past her. It looked like a spider made of metal, with a head sticking out of its body, and many eyes. She froze, afraid that the creature would notice her. Fortunately, her magic worked, and the creature did not turn on her, but entered the dinning room and addressed the gathered there. She eavesdropped on the rest of the conversation, crouching down next to the door.

„So let's start with some basic knowledge. First, your Xadia is a planet floating in the cold void of space... And it's round... „ said the woman named Iath .

„Who do you take us for? We are not idiots, that was proven long ago.„ Miriam said with offense in her voice.

„Well, I wanted to make sure... Xadia is one of the countless Planets in the endless black void of space. Many of them are inhabited by completely alien species, Civilizations that you can't even imagine. We came from many different places, but we came for one reason only, Klest came into possession of some information about your planet. You must know that it is located in a very poorly explored region of the Galaxy, called the Ravaged

Zone. It is a very dangerous place, supposedly full of white demons and ruled here by the ruler of the seven heavens. On the way here we passed by several ships, whose affiliation we could not recognize, but they seemed to have hostile Intentions. Unfortunately, we did not expect that this planet would be too.„ She explained in a calm voice with a hint of irritation.

„Klest financed this expedition with the money of her father, the Archduke of Carurystal.„ The man posing as a dwarf explained. „I am a quartermaster, and a geologist by education, which allowed me to gain quite a fortune here. Iath is the biologist and doctor, Iron Hand, He is our technician and engineer, as well as a specialist in a certain field of history. Shash is our weapons specialist, and Damien was our co-pilot, as well as a historian and linguist. Well... He died some time ago. During the depressurization of the ship, his lungs were damaged, and he never recovered. To be honest, however, at the end of his life he was very happy...„ Brumi paused significantly, and then Miriam interrupted.

"I want to make sure you're talking about the same Damien who was Prince Calum's father ?" Her voice was thick with surprise and disbelief. She heard a gasp and the fort's host said.

„Yes, himself. Well, he was the most romantic of us all... He fit in here the best. He died young, but he managed to start a family... That's probably why the boy can use magic...”

"Not only because of that..." Klest spoke up. "His family on his mother's side is of Azlantean descent. I discovered that when I found that ship. That's why I'm here."

„ It's very good that you found this ship, although I don't think it will be able to fly off this planet. „ she heard a metallic voice belonging to the many-legged creature.

„Well, we probably won't fly away, because if you ask me... Just to be on the safe side, I overloaded the reactor, causing a limited

nuclear explosion.„ Klest said with a strange amusement in her head.

There was silence. She wasn't sure what a nuclear explosion was, but she remembered the earthquake, and the cloud of smoke, so she had a rough idea that there had been a huge explosion.

„I'm not even surprised. Please just tell me you found some information there that will be useful to us. „ Iath said , and Klest laughed shortly and replied.

„Yes, I think I know what I found here, the contact details of a very old relay station of the First Ones... It could save us, but not only that... The problem is that something happened in the galaxy. The level of magic on the planet has increased, I think you've felt it, Iath, right? In addition, cultists have appeared. Cultists of the Great Old Ones, who are looking for the same thing as we are. They probably started their activity earlier, but you know what kind of allies they have. Even if it's not about finding this relay station, it may turn out that they will bring contact with the Mi-Go, the Dep Ones, or the Scylredi. That's why we have to hurry! Do you understand?”

„I don't understand anything! What Scylredi ? And what First Ones are you talking about?„ the Dark Mage exclaimed angrily, and then the Spider creature spoke again.

„ They created us, the anacites , and to this day we honor them for it, or at least most of us do. They created the dragon-elven hybrids here, like your friend... They are your ancestors, after all...”

She heard the queen's cousin get up from the table, probably in agitation, but then she heard a voice behind her. She turned around and saw a creature slowly walking towards her. She was tall and looked almost human, but had a paler complexion. Her eyes were large and blue, devoid of whites, glowing with an inner light, similar to the one that came out of Klest's eyes. She had long scarlet hair that fell to her shoulders, the same color as the

woman who had brought them here... It was her sister, whom they had mentioned earlier. Except she wasn't human... She had large membranous wings on her back, and claws on her hands, which resembled the limbs of some predatory creature. A thin down of red hair grew over her shoulders and neck. She made a strange, slightly clacking sound. She seemed to be listening, with very long animal ears. I had the impression that she was looking for something, and she quickly guessed what. She tried to stay still, but the creature approached slowly. It clattered and listened, as if trying to detect something by listening for the echo. She was afraid of the creature, and stopped breathing so that the creature would not detect her.

„It's here-here-here! But where-where!„ The creature called, and then its glowing blue eyes landed on her. She took off running the moment it lunged at her. She only took a few steps before its long claws caught her cloak, tearing it open. She fell and rolled to the side.

„Stop-Stop! Don't move! Stay-Stay! „ The creature called. She punched it in the face, blood gushing from its nose. The creature hissed and tried to strike her with its claws, but she jumped back, cracks appearing where it hit. She created several illusionary reflections of herself, and tried to stab the creature, taking advantage of the fact that it wouldn't know which reflection attacked. However, it was so agile that it simply dodged all the attacks and tore apart two of the four reflections she had created. She cursed, but then she had an idea and created a flash of light. The creature had eyes like nocturnal animals, so she guessed that this would blind it. It worked, because the creature only screamed loudly and covered its eyes. She knew she should run, but she had to get rid of this creature, or it would track her down again. She was about to deal a fatal blow when suddenly Klest jumped out of the door, and with one lightning-fast moment she knocked the weapon out of her hand, and with the other she knocked it down, breaking her ribs in the process. She choked on blood, and the woman with scarlet hair threw her against the wall, stunning her, and ran to her sister, hugging her. The others ran out, and a large lizard holding a weapon, supposedly for a club or an axe,

walked up to her, aimed it at her neck. The others looked at her in surprise, except for Rao, in whose two-colored eyes she saw rage. It clenched its fists and screamed furiously.

„ She is from the snake path! „ he pointed to the place where the claws had given her cloak, where he saw the symbol of the two-headed snake…

Chapter End Notes

I invite you to comment on the next chapter of my fanfic.
I hope I didn't mix up the pronouns of Rao.

Traveling and meetings - part one

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She yawned as she looked at the Silverwing's navigation instruments. She wondered why she had decided to take this flight and help young Frosta. She was her aunt, albeit a step”aunt, and so was her wife, so it was only right that they help her. But that wasn't all. Actually, everyone should help another person in such a situation, so if there was even a small chance that they could help the Ice Princess recover from this terrible Curse, they should take. She heard what Halo had said. She couldn't believe that the woman she had once considered a friend, who could have been her sister-in-law if their fate had been different, could say such things... She didn't understand why this woman hadn't helped Frosta right away, after all she had sworn to take care of her. It was always said that for the Star Sisters, promises were sacred. Who was she working with, who was this creature, She couldn't see, but she was definitely Wicked. If this person cursed the girl in such a terrible way, he must have been evil to the core of his black heart. She didn't see how all this connected with the spell that Shadow Weaver had cast. Could this vile woman be working with this Charon in some way, that couldn't be ruled out You could expect anything from her. But that didn't matter, all that mattered was how to help Frosta. But how will they convince the dark sorceress to remove the spell from the girl? She knew that this was an extremely difficult undertaking, just getting to the camp might be impossible. Their only hope was that the Nightgale in question would prove to be someone worthy of the hopes Frosta had placed in her, though if she was only half as bad as her mother, then their chances were probably slim. There was that girl too… Supposedly Catra's sister, who was supposed to travel with

Shadow Weaver, but they didn't know much about her, except that she was under the influence of a dark sorcerer. She sighed and looked at the girl sitting in the chair behind her. Her eyes were closed, and that strange creature wrapped itself around her like a cloak, She could tell by hearing her breathing that she was only pretending to sleep. After all, she was a mother of two growing children, a toddler, and another baby due soon. … She could sense when someone was pretending to want to sleep. Next to her in the co-pilot's seat sat a Seahawk… He stared intently at the instruments, all Pale, he really didn't like flying. And now this journey had gotten longer…

Shortly after takeoff, they discovered that the entire fleet of vehicles had flown out of the Storm, heading North. They then had to make a decision. Should they follow them or head for Castle Crypto… It was Frosta who made the choice.

„Let's go after them, in the worst case, we'll just find out what they're planning, and that will probably help Glimmer too.„ she said with her head down. Well, they did as she wanted, now she felt like it was a good choice. They flew to The Northern Reaches, and they were already close to the place where they had recently explored ancient ruins. That was probably good. However, she was worried about where Lonnie had gotten so many ships. From what she understood, they must have had at least one, which they had flown to the wedding in. It was on it that Shadow Weaver and that nasty girl who Traveled with her came here. But where did the rest come from? Could it be that the People's Rebellion had support from off-planet? She could only hope that they weren't so crazy as to ally with the Scions of Horde Prime. Fortunately, their ship had light cloaking fields, and was practically undetectable by radar. Well, thanks to that, her grandmother managed to kill the Old Scorpion King. It was a True miracle of early technology, no matter what anyone said about them. They just had to be careful to keep their distance, not to fly too close, not too far away. And she also had to try not to fall asleep, which was hard considering she was getting on in years. She yawned and spoke to Frosty .

„I think they'll be landing soon. I need to find a proper landing spot, but it won't be easy, because there are mountains and glaciers here, and we can't stay too close to the rebels. So strap yourself in tight, and watch out so you don't bite your tongue off!

Frosta immediately opened her eyes, confirming her suspicions, and Seahawk swallowed for a moment and said.

„ It's not that I'm afraid, because no and I'm afraid of absolutely nothing. But you know, I'll be a father soon, and I'd like to see my child, so try not to kill us, okay?„ he looked at her pleadingly, and she smiled at him and replied.

"Well, I'll make sure we all survive, are you happy?" she said and he nodded uncertainly, but then Frosta said.

„I can help. I still have your power, and I think I can make it easier for you to land! Fine. Only if you opened a door or a hatch."

She thought for a moment and answered her.

„This has a vertical take-off mode, and all you have to do is open your own at the bottom, but we have to find a place that's pretty far away, and be careful not to fall out, because there are no seat belts or anything to hold you, do you understand?„ she looked at her young friend, who was already unbuckling her seat belts to go to the back of the Silverwing.

Carefully, so as not to be detected, they approached the vast glacier that stretched over the mountaintops. Below them was that damned city of Elder Things who seemed to have enslaved Shogi and his kin. The weather was fine in the area, though no bright moons had risen yet.

"Alright Frosta, let's do this!" she called out and began to approach the landing. The Seahawk gripped the armrests tightly, and she tried to hover in midair. She opened the cargo hatches, despite the safety systems warning her not to. She gritted her teeth and held onto the controls. This machine was magnificent, but it was a few thousand years old and probably wasn't meant to

fly with the hatches open. They began to shake, and she could feel the entire machine bending under the forces pressing down on it. She gritted her teeth and felt the power behind her. The navigational instruments showed that the ground was changing, the distance from the ground was decreasing, and what was underneath the plane was changing shape. She felt the piercing cold from where the Ice Princess was. She risked a look behind her, and saw that Frosta was actually hanging on Shogi's tentacles, using her power to shape the ice below. After a moment, she called out to the girl.

„You can stop, I think that's enough! „ and she started to get ready to log in. Frosta stopped using her power, and then they started to land. To everyone but her, the impact with the ice was surprising, Seahawk bit his tongue, and Frosta hit her head. The glacier crunched under the weight of their vehicle, but it didn't break , so she breathed a sigh of relief, then unbuckled herself and looked at the others.

„So what now?„ She asked them, wondering what they should do.

The Smiley watched as they tended to her father, who had recovered remarkably quickly from the shock of learning the truth about her. No wonder, after all, he had once been the ruler of the planet, and had led an entire army. There were few things that could move him. Despite this, deep down she felt disappointment. She knew it was irrational, but a part of her soul wanted him to do something, sit down and breathe heavily, trying to digest this news, or maybe do something else, like announce to everyone that he had found another daughter. She had asked him not to do it, but even so, it would be... It would make her feel like... she was part of it all. Well, he had already found out once that he had a missing daughter... The second time around it was clearly not as shocking... *Even that. I was robbed. Even that was taken from me*. She thought bitterly, but she couldn't help it. After all, she had to prepare everything so that her rights could be fulfilled. It took time, and that was why she was late… It didn't matter, he

was never her family anyway. Not him… She gritted her teeth, and then Ivy walked up to her and put a hand on her shoulder. She looked at the android she smiled with her mask. She felt better, you always felt better when Ivi was around.

Finally, a priest cast a spell and her father was able to use his hand skillfully. Then he looked at Daria, and she saw curiosity in his eyes, but also concern.

„Despara ...„ he said, and then she corrected him.

„Commander Despara, or First Blade, such are the titles I am entitled to.„ she said in a voice distorted by the mask, and Antares he nodded and said.

"Commander Despara has brought important news that must be relayed to the rest of the fleet command.... Call a meeting of the General Staff immediately.„ ordered the Commander of the Fearless Armada. Then he gave her a thoughtful look. He probably wondered who she was, but she wouldn't explain everything to him yet. Let him think about it some more, she has time. For now, he doesn't have to know anything, When the time comes, everything will be brighter than a supernova... Soon an armored personnel carrier and an off-road vehicle arrived for them, the Lord Admiral chose the latter, he didn't want to hide from the enemy behind armored plates. With reluctance she had to admit that he was damn brave. Most leaders after an attempt on their lives would try to hide in a bunker, and with paranoid passion would search for those guilty of what happened. Together with Ivy, she got into the carrier, because he would prefer to be alone. Inside, she took a deep breath, and hugged the Android. She felt the phantom pain radiating from artificial limbs. Even though she had prosthetics, wonderful prosthetics, created by an ancient civilization, she was still in constant pain. There was nothing she could do about it. All she could do was try to control the pain. She preferred not to take painkillers, because they would set her off, not to mention addiction. She tried not to show any pain in front of Ivi, because she was indirectly responsible for her suffering. After a while, the pain subsided, and she began to purr quietly,

while her... companion watched the metal marbles floating in the air, which calmed her... Everyone had some kind of trauma...

After about half an hour they arrived at the place where they got out of the transporter and prepared for the staff meeting. Antares did not choose any government building, because they were now associated with the regime of a mad tyrant. At least that's what he explained to her, and she had no reason not to believe him. A muscular man with slightly androgynous facial features was waiting for them in front of the tent. He was dressed in the uniform of a higher ranking officer. As soon as he saw their commander, he ran towards him and said.

„I am glad, Lord… Protector, that nothing happened!„ there was relief in his voice. Antares nodded and said.

„It might have been difficult if it weren't for Commander Despara. „ He pointed at her and the man looked in her direction, and she saw gratitude in his eyes. She suppressed a smile, because this was someone with a dog's disposition, which in her case was a bit ironic, and said.

„You must be Commander Reese, I've heard a lot about your achievements both on the battlefield and when you commanded ships during space battles.”

The man blushed, which showed that he wasn't very good at hiding his emotions, and then he said.

„I am grateful for saving my commander…„ and He gave her his hand. This man and would have survived even a week on the Apostate. She shook his hand, and they entered the tent together.

„You must know, Lord Protector, that reinforcements have arrived from outside the Ravaged Zone... They include not only our troops, but forces we did not expect to arrive... „ He spoke, but Antares interrupted him.

„Commander Despara explained everything to me.„ he said and indicated that they should go inside the tent…

„The bastards are really determined to go to this gods forsaken place.„ Lady Ka told her, smiling as always, that is with a mixture of cruelty.

"I've been here before, and it's something to look for if you know certain things," she said thoughtfully to the woman sitting next to her.

They had been flying for several hours now, at a steady speed. They had kept up with the others, and were flying high in the stratosphere. They had managed to remain undetected, and at the same time detect the rebel ships. In fact, it was only possible because one of the ships did not have a military jamming system, she guessed it was the same ship that Shadow Weaver had brought here. She wondered, Was the woman on board, probably because where else could she be? Probably wanted to be as close to her sister as possible, so she could control her more easily. She certainly didn't want to repeat the same mistake that had happened to Adora ... She was worried, however, that nothing was detecting Netossa's ship, but it was a creation of the First Ones, and it most likely had a jamming system far beyond anything they had. They could only guess that the general and the Ice Princess had followed the ships. If it had happened otherwise... Actually, that was a good thing too, because she wanted to finally confront the cursed sorcerer...

I am not going there for Revenge, but to help her friend… she mentally instructed herself, but she still felt angry… She just wasn't sure who… The accusations against her father, the escape of that cursed woman and her monstrous assistant, the death of the guards, what happened to Frosta, and finally the kidnapping of Entrapta and the Empress. She wasn't sure which of these things made her feel more Angry, but she knew she had to control herself, at least for a while longer. It wasn't easy when you were around Someone like Lady Ka and her Subordinates.

She had the impression that the woman was constantly smiling mockingly at her, although it was hard to take what it was personally, because she smiled at everyone in a similar way. She kept nervously tapping the armrests of the chair with her mechanical fingers. There was also this Graag... He was a short individual, but he was proportionally built. His arm and leg were replaced with cybernetic prosthetics. There was something nasty about him, but she wasn't sure what. He was constantly cursing under his breath, but she couldn't recognize the language he spoke, but she knew practically no other language ... And there was this insectoid, belonging to the same species as that annoying Ashurk , but he seemed to be much less irritating ... He had two pistols attached to his forearms, which he could draw with a slight movement of the wrist, when they moved forward. He captured them and put them away every now and then, throwing Her a defiant look ...

She knew that there were Star siblings in this fleet, as well as that lying Saihe, who accused her father of all those crimes. For now, she decided not to inform on him, although she wasn't sure why. Maybe because living in the Fright zone she had learned that it was better to never inform on anyone, which was wise when someone like Shadow Weaver was your guardian. Maybe she just didn't want to slow down the whole expedition, or maybe she just wanted to believe in him... As if she couldn't accept that she had the right to be happy. To a family that she loved, and that cared about her. She simply had to allow herself to be happy. She had to cast aside all doubts... Otherwise... She simply couldn't imagine what she would do if it turned out otherwise... She wouldn't survive this...

Shortly after it turned out that the ships were flying north, Lady Ka approached her and with a gloomy face said.

„We have a fucking problem... The recon drones have approached those Ships. They belong to the Shadows of Tarak, your uncle's former subordinates...„ She looked at her meaningfully, her one eye showing rage, as well as fear.

„Should we be afraid of them? Do they pose a threat to the entire planet?„ and she asked the woman, feeling uneasy herself. Lady Ka grimaced and said.

„What the fuck do you think? They're fucking terrorists, enemies of the Lord Admiral... I mean, the Lord Protector... Who do you think did this to me?” she pointed at the mask covering half of her face. She felt as if an inner light was shining in the three emeralds. For a moment the arrangement of the gems seemed familiar to her, but she shook her head, because what she was thinking was absurd...

"I didn't know that. I'm sorry about that." She said carefully, but the Lord Admiral's left better hand just chuckled and said.

„Well, thanks to your uncle I managed to get a job with your father... I owe a hell of a lot to your family!„ she laughed again, and she felt irritation, so much that Melog turned slightly red, and she asked.

„This changes everything, we have to get near as soon as possible and free Frosta and my sister. I can take you with Malog's help ... Then nothing is old on the usual.„ she said to the information and intelligence officer, smiled and said.

„Good idea, but I'm not sure I should let you do that. Your father currently gives me his other hand, and maybe more, if you get hurt.”

„What do you mean, the other hand?„ She looked at the prosthesis, and then Lady Ka became confused and said.

„ Well, there are certain things between Antares and me that do not concern you.”

She frowned and said.

„Remember, I am the heir of the Lord Admiral, so you should tell me everything.„ she said, narrowing her eyes. She extended her claws, then immediately retracted them. She might not like this

woman, but she had no intention of clashing with her now. She only intended to save her sister, Frosta, Entrapta ... A lot of people. She felt the weight of responsibility suddenly overwhelm her. She rubbed her cheeks and said.

"Okay, well, why don't you land nearby and I'll try to get a few of you through Nearby, okay?" she said, and the Lady thought for a moment, then extended her hand, one artificial and one metal, and shook it.

„ Yes, that's a good plan, we'll figure out what we're going to do on site.”

Chapter End Notes

This isn't my best chapter, I apologize for that

Traveling and meetings - Part Two

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

„I think it would be best if we went there without hiding, so they could see us. What do you think, aunt?„ she looked at Netossa , who smiled at her.

„We'll do as you please, if you really trust this Nightgale.„ she said in an almost indifferent tone, but she could already tell when people wanted to suggest something between the words. The general wanted to let her know if she really considered that young sorcerer trustworthy. She wasn't sure if she could trust Nightgale, but she wanted to try, so she nodded and together they set off towards the camp. She walked in front, although to tell the truth Netossa had a greater right to represent them, because after all she was the real princess, not someone who was allowed to use that title just out of pity It was dark, and cold because of the glacier, but she didn't care. They had to get there and meet Shadow Weaver... She was afraid of it, probably everyone who knew this woman was at least a little afraid of her. But she had to be strong, not only because she had come after a request to the dark sorcerer, but also because she had to somehow make sure that nothing would happen to her companions.

Netossa walked next to her, and a little further along walked Seahawk, who held his hands close to the hilt of his rapier. Shogi took the form of a creature similar to a Fox. He only had four eyes, so he looked almost like an ordinary local animal. She saw stars and moons shining in the sky, she had heard that some people from other planets saw hints about the future in them, she wanted it to be true, and so that she could see in them what might await her in the coming hours. Now she regretted letting her friends fly here with her, because it exposed them to the risk

of being captured, or even something even worse happening to them...

A shout tore her from her thoughts.

„Halt! Don't come any closer! Tell me who you are!„ She heard a voice, speaking with a strange accent, whose source she couldn't locate. Netossa wanted to surround them with an energy net, but she showed her not to do it, because they had to talk to them anyway, not wait behind cover.

„I am a princess... I am Frosta, and these are my friends Princess Netossa and Prince Consort Seahawk. I came here to speak with your commander.„ She said uncertainly, then there was silence, and finally the same person spoke.

„Okay, you can go, just don't try anything!„ and then a few well-camouflaged soldiers emerged from between the stones. She had seen one or two before, but she saw that Netossa didn't show the slightest surprise, so she probably saw most of them, or hid her surprise very well. They were surrounded by a dozen soldiers. Most of them looked like relatives of Catra's friend, she thought his name was Rogelio, but they looked like they were more dangerous than him.. There were also a few tall cat-like people, several similar ones also served in the Lord Admiral's army and she had heard that Catra was half one of them. There was also someone who she had initially taken for Saihe, but then she saw that he had long antennae and insect eyes.

„Who exactly are you?„ Netossa asked looking at them carefully, and then the soldier looked at her and smiling with a mouth full of sharp teeth said in a hard voice.

„We are the Shadows of Tarak.„ and he finished as if that explained everything.

„But what does that mean? After all, Tarak is the planet from which Lord Admiral Antares comes, you know the father of the Grand Marshal and so on... But you do not serve him?„ the

general continued, looking at them carefully. One of the soldiers, a black-furred catwoman, spat with contempt, and said.

„We're here to Get this son of a bitch. We've been trying to Get him for thirty years, but we can't. But now we have a chance...”

She thought for a moment before asking.

„So it's all true...„ she said in a hushed voice. „Because recently someone came and told a lot about Catra's father. He said h ande did terrible things.”

Catwoman laughed darkly.

„Well, whatever you heard, the truth is much worse. This Catra is the boss's niece… I wonder if she's half as mean and tough as she is? Or his sister, or her sister... „ she said, looking at them carefully.

"Catra is the best friend I've ever had! She's strong, tough, and very cunning... Does that mean her Uncle is here too? Does she even have an uncle? Is he nice? I mean, you said he wasn't, but the same could be said about Catra, and she turned out to be a good friend!" She asked looking at the soldier, and everyone else laughed hoarsely.

„You do have a sense of humor... Igzar the Nice One? Good one!”

They walked for a while longer until they reached the fruit, which consisted mainly of several tents and ships that had landed next to each other.

„This is what a military camp looks like, you've probably never seen one?„ said a lizard looking like a commander. She snorted and said.

„Of course I've seen it, and more than once.. Haven't you heard that we had a thirty-year war here?„ she looked at him with absolute superiority, and then Netossa laughed.

„I spent half my life in Military camps... I fought when you were probably still an egg somewhere.„ The ruler of Armoria gave him a slightly contemptuous look, and the lizard opened his mouth as if to say something, but then changed his mind and fell silent with a grim expression. The second feline soldier laughed surprisingly friendly and said.

„We usually forget that this is not a pretty land of glitter and rainbows. We talked to former Cadets and their training can amaze even the Vesks. But you are the ones who won the war... And even your planet is not in ruins, I think we should learn something from you.„ she said and they continued walking forward. She also saw former Cadets, who were looking at her with surprise and consternation. She guessed no one expected princess to come here. In the distance, they saw that many of them were working on something trapped in the glacier. From this distance, however, she was unable to judge. Seahawk was giving everyone serious looks, only that it even seemed to salute him instinctively.

Finally they were led to a tent over which the Banner of the People's Rebellion flew. She took a deep breath as they entered.

There they saw Lonnie, who had scars on her face from Catra's claws. She had the impression that she had aged somehow. Or maybe she just looked like that because she seemed exhausted Or maybe they had all aged over the weeks? She didn't know.

Next to the Comrade General stood a large black tomcat, with gray fur and a body covered in scars. Some of his body parts were mechanical, like Jewelstar He watched them darkly, like… a cat watching a mouse… Seahawk put his hand on his rapier and glared at the warrior, who only smiled at him, showing his metal teeth, as if to tell him to try something stupid, but then Lonnie gave them a warning look and said.

„Let's wait for my co-commander.”

Netossa snorted and said in a sharp voice.

"Really, Lonnie? Have you stooped so low as to share power with someone like Shadow Weaver?"

And then a calm, somewhat monotonous voice sounded behind them.

„The Grimmy is not here. But fortunately you have here a being absolutely perfect, aawesome and almost unique. „ they turned and See catgirl. For a moment she thought it was Catra... but then it was White Who is talking to.

„ Yes, it's me, the other one... Well, hello, what are you doing? „ a white”haired girl with strange glasses stood behind her and waved at them, smiling friendly.

Once, if someone told her that a smuggler, a clone, an aricorn, and a droid were playing cards, she would have thought it was the beginning of some joke, but it turned out that this was exactly what her life was like... Despite everything, she didn't complain, and she had to admit that she hadn't had such a good time in a long time.

„Okay, now Swift Wind deals the cards. „ She said and then Lilka started dealing the cards on behalf of this Aricorn She had to admit that he played quite well. Although still worse than Wrongdak, it probably had to do with his training and ability to predict the enemy's behavior, although it must be admitted that he was very bad at bluffing. In this respect, Emiliy was superior to everyone for obvious reasons. In fact, she was very happy that she could finally play cards with someone who yelled at each other. Besides, Eti didn't understand why she played if she couldn't cheat. To her surprise, the locals knew the rules of playing cards with the Harrow deck, although of course they did not know its more mystical applications, or at least that's what Swiftwind claimed. It did not bother her, because she was not interested in card fortune telling anyway. She managed to win this hand, so she took a few chips, which of course had no real value

She looked at Wrongdak. Perhaps one day she would play him one-on-one, although then the stakes would be something completely different…

And at that moment Lonnie's voice rang out from the speakers, calling Eti to stay in her tent, because a delegation from the queen had arrived. She sighed and told the others to clear away the cards, and went to Eti's cabin. It wasn't locked, which sometimes happened to the cat girl when she felt worse, so she went inside and saw Eti dressing quickly, and Rosie was sitting on the bed next to her, wrapped only in sheets. The white-haired girl was scared and all red with embarrassment. She should have expected it, and to tell the truth, she was glad that their relationship had finally developed in this direction, so she smiled at the girl to let her understand that she wasn’t angry at her or anything like that.

„You've heard the news, I guess I'll leave you and see what's up with the rest. „ she said and winked at Rosie once more, then left, happy for her charges.

The Smiley thought it was funny, that everyone was trying to very ostentatiously pretend that she wasn't there, and at the same time her presence dominated the entire meeting of the General Staff. Antares first explained to everyone that nothing had happened to him, and also described the course of the assassination attempt on his life. She knew that not everyone in the command liked her father, but no one wished him dead... After all, it would mean the failure of the entire expedition and no one wanted to allow that. She straightened her back and watched the gathered people carefully, wondering what they thought of her... But in fact, it didn't matter. Only one person's opinion mattered, and he had probably already made a decision about it... Or maybe not? We'll see. Ivi stood next to her, encouraging her. She didn't need support, but she was grateful for it.

„Perhaps it was a mistake to leave Lady Ka on Etheria to support your daughter.„ Said the silver-scaled Dragonkin whose name was Tarel.„ She may have been quite a… unusual person, but it must be admitted that she was quite good at her job.

The Lord Protector nodded and said.

„You are indeed right, but there is not much you can do about it. We must wait until she fulfills His task and returns to His duties…"

At this point she spoke up.

"I can take care of those matters, though not today. I've brought with me several security specialists from Apostate, and they'll guarantee your safety with their lives. That's no exaggeration, Lord Protector, the Drow take security very seriously," she explained, and then all eyes turned to her, as if unsure if she was even allowed to speak... But then Henoh spoke up.

"I understand that this attack will be met with your response?"

The son of the Archduke of Carurystal He was a tall man with hair the color of blood, and cold blue eyes that glowed as if with an inner light. Like most of his siblings, he looked twenty years old, although of course he was much older. As far as she could judge male beauty, he was quite handsome, and probably the melancholy visible on his face made him even more attractive.

„No, there is no point in changing the course of war because of an attempt on my life. That would be petty, and very Unwise.„ Said the commander of the Fearless Armada.

„It is truly fascinating that you are so reserved and prudent, despite the rumors circulating about you." Said the Dragonkin. Her father, however, ignored the obvious quip, and continued the discussion.

„Despite everything, I think we should start some talks with Horde Ultimate, if only to find out who he really is. Besides, striving for peace looks good in the media, but we don't necessarily have to

adjust our actions to our messages, of course.„ he spoke thoughtfully, his voice absolutely composed. Everyone listened to him, and no one dared to interrupt him. He had solidified his reputation with his recent victories... She would have to keep that in mind when she did what she planned. Then they discussed less important elements of further warfare, and then There were several formal greetings with the new members of the General Staff. First of all, this time the son of the Archduke officially introduced himself, and then Draxes greeted him . He was a Fetchling , a being tainted by the plane of shadow. He was a Fetchling, a creature corrupted by the plane of shadow. These creatures were the only non-drow who could hold high positions, and were therefore an exception in the usually speciesist society of the Apostate.. Despite this, obstacles were always thrown in his way, although in the case of Drow society it should rather be called open traps, but he survived and that is why she made him de facto her deputy and person of management. Apart from him there was also Ragaz , the commander of her orcs. He was a free orc and thanks to that she could hire him. His soldiers were famous for their unwavering loyalty even for orcs, so she assumed that they would be helpful to her here. The last one was the one whose presence she did not want. Janos Di Vir He was the Lictor of the Order of the Eclipse, and an exceptionally dangerous man, at least considering what she intended to do. However, he had the strongest army and a powerful fleet, no one could underestimate him, he was de facto equal to Antares. Her father, accepting the help of the Hellknights never expected that it would escalate in such a way. However, she had the impression that something had happened that she didn't know about... She knew that three subordinates were missing from the Lord's staff, or rather two and one person who had traveled with the Dauntless Armada. From what she had heard, Lady Ka and Lady Sorrowflame had remained on Etheria to fulfill the orders of their commander and help... that girl. She had also heard a little about what had happened on that planet, and from what she had understood, the Lady of Blades was strangely connected to some dark sorceress, and an aristocrat from Carystal. Henoh, who was formally the heir and in fact his father's deputy, had told her a bit about the couple. And

she knew well that Archduke Kane Adamson knew more than everyone thought. That was probably why Janos had come here. He was not guided by the good order, but by his attachment to his adopted daughter. She had to respect him for that, few were willing to risk their children so much, especially among those with such strict morality... Would her father be willing to do something like that for any of his children? At the thought, she laughed out loud, until everyone present looked at her. Then the Lord Admiral spoke.

„From now on, Despara will be my deputy, and in my absence, everyone is to address her.„ he said in a hard tone, so much so that even She looked behind him in surprise. She hadn't expected that. She had expected Antares to give her some power, but she hadn't expected her to become his right hand either. It seemed like a good solution, because it gave her almost unlimited Power, but she also knew that it was associated with certain problems. First, many would envy her this honor, including the Lord Admiral's left hand... Although she would have to deal with her in her own way. In addition, her official position tied her hands and limited her room to maneuver… She looked at Antares and saw that he was watching her reaction. She began to suspect certain things, so she simply said it.

„Thank you for this honor and I promise to fulfill my duties with absolute dedication.„ She said in Careful, and everyone calmed down a little, as if they expected her to give the orders of execution right away. Another hour passed, during which she practically did not speak, until finally everyone dispersed, and she also intended to go, because she had a more important task to do, but her father stopped her.

"I'd like to discuss a few things with you," he said, and she winced, her scars stretching and she said.

„We'll do it tomorrow, now I have to leave for a while.„ her voice was hard and confident, as if she wasn't talking to a man who could kill millions in the name of achieving his goals. Antares frowned, and said in a surprisingly caring voice.

„I would like to speak with you about the matter of your heritage, and our family's past. I already have two daughters, and I will soon be able to regain a third. At least too two seem strong enough to bear the burden of power over what I can manage to… secure. I would not want everything to be ruined by a future conflict between siblings that would tear my domain apart.”

She smiled under her mask and then said cheekily .

„ In your case, you decided to solve this problem in advance, right?”

This time his gaze became much more penetrating, so it took a moment before he spoke slowly and thoughtfully.

„It was a necessity, and in fact it was an act of grace. The Taint that haunts our family was particularly strong in them. That is why you were… you were all created… I take it that Jantar hid you?„ He tilted his head, clearly intrigued.

"Oh no, I just didn't meet his standards... I failed a certain test, and he sold me to the Drow on Apostate... It was difficult... But as you can see, I've managed to accomplish quite a bit, and I'm almost in one piece..." She tapped her prosthetic, and then the Admiral became thoughtful and asked one more question.

„Wasn't there another one? Since I If he created you without telling me anything, and on top of that he took you away from me, he could do it again?”

She hesitated, and immediately cursed herself inwardly, because it couldn't escape the attention of someone like the Lord Admiral. She felt tempted to tell him the truth, because maybe it would make it easier to fulfill her mission... Atonement for what she hadn't done. But no, she couldn't trust him, no one with even a shred of sense could trust Felix Antares . But she had to say something, so she did what true liars did, which was tell part of the truth.

„Yes, she was, but she didn't live up to what was required of her, even more than I did, and she died during one of the tests.„ she said, involuntarily feeling a surge of sadness, although she was the one responsible for what happened then. The Lord Admiral nodded, for him the topic was over, so she decided it was time to calm him down a bit.

„ As for whether there might be any disagreements between me and …" she had to force herself to say the name. "Catra, don't worry. I have no intention of taking anything you give her, and she certainly won't take anything I want from me..."„ She said with the same deep thought as her father. She wasn't sure if he believed her, he certainly wouldn't completely do it, he was a reasonable man after all, and he knew how things were Even in the most normal families.

„Now please I would like to leave, I am tired from a very long journey and I need rest... „ she said not entirely lying, because she was indeed tired, but she still intended to do a few things that would be really exhausting. The Lord Admiral slowly nodded and let her go.

Together with Ivi they went beyond military camp and even outside the city. They found low patterns and stopped there . She touched her hand and it became almost liquid. She pulled out a small sphere made of white metal. An ancient artifact of the First Ones, valuable even for representatives of this unimaginably powerful race. It was her greatest acquisition, which she had obtained in the core of the Apostate... She paid a lot for it, but she still thought it was a good deal. Sometimes, for such treasures, entire nations were surrendered to the flames. She had no reason to complain, a life spent in pain was not much instead of the possibility of breaking the warp of time and space... Ivi approached her, and then she embraced her and opened the sphere. A miniature model of the universe stood open before her and she began to use it to her mind. The vastness of the universe tried to crush her, to crush her mind, but after what she had

experienced, her Will was harder than adamantium . She found the place she wanted to go, and then she sought out a certain person. Even though she felt the winds of doom blowing through the space between worlds, and heard the insane music coming from Aztatoth's court, she focused her thoughts and with a single stroke of her blade cut a rift in spacetime. She removed her mask, kissed Ivi , and together they entered the wound in reality.

She watched the military camp. It wasn't a new sight for her, after all, she had spent her entire childhood in one like that. This one looked really professional. It was obvious that the soldiers of the Shadows of Tarak really knew their job. But after all, they had been at war for thirty years, if Lady Ka could be believed.. Her subordinates were much less disciplined, if Shadow Weaver saw such a lack of focus on their goal and how easily they got distracted by the slightest thing, she would… Damn, why was she thinking about that lousy woman, after all, she no longer ruled her life... But she was still there somewhere, and until she finally solved her problem, she would always try to take away her happiness. She had the impression that she had made it her life's goal to take away her happiness... But enough of this! Today everything would end... No! She couldn't let Anger and Fury get the better of what she had to do. She had to constantly remember that she had come here to save Frosta and the others, there would be time later.

„They've got a swing, you sons of bitches!„ Lady Ka said and giggled standing next to her.

„You said yourself that this is an army, and they took half of the Cadets with them. But what are they looking for here?„ she thought aloud, and the woman in the half-mask said.

„Which we'll have to find out. I hope your pet is really as good at hiding others as you claim.„ She looked at Melog , who gave her an irritated look.

„Melog is not a pet, I do not want you to talk about him like that, do we understand each other?„ You returned coldly to Lady Ka, who smiled at her, but there was no trace of humor in her one eye.

„Yes, Sir!„ She called and laughed again. She gritted her teeth but said nothing, just motioned for her to continue.

It turned out that the power of her companions was enough to remain unnoticed . She wasn't sure what these people were planning, but she saw something strange in the distance. Some huge object hidden in the glacier... They were in a place where not so long ago she had explored an ancient city with her friends. She remembered that there were remains of the first ones, who as always tried to kill her. She wondered if this was not what Shadow Weaver and Lonnie were looking for, an ancient weapon that could turn the Scales of Victory.

In addition to Lady Ka, Graag had gone with her, and that insectoid, and a few of the woman's other dogs. She still wasn't sure if she should take them with her. She was increasingly uncomfortable around Lady Ka, and sometimes she felt like it wasn't the People's Rebellion she really had to fear.

And then she saw Frosta, walking with Netossa and Seahawk and Shogi, surrounded by a few soldiers. She didn't seem scared and was talking to them about something, to tell the truth, all Three seemed very tired, although she also had the impression that the Ice Princess was nervous too. She understood her, after all, she had a conversation with Shadow Weaver waiting for her, And it was never easy. They all entered the tent, and then they talked for a while, Netossa seemed to be accusing Lonnie of being in alliance with the dark sorceress. But she didn't listen carefully, because she saw her. Her sister was walking slowly, with a rifle on her back, wrapped in a cloak, and behind her was the white-haired girl who had almost killed Adora. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Lady Ka clench her metal hand, and she saw anger in her eyes. She knew she should think about it right away, but then the words came out.

„ The Grimmy is not here. But fortunately you have here a being absolutely perfect, aawesome and almost unique. „ Said her sister. It was not hard to guess who she was, this Grim , but immediately after that Frosta, Lonnie, and a want came out of the tent whom she had never seen before, but she immediately realized Who she was.

„How on earth is that bastard still alive!„ Lady Ka, standing next to her, muttered.

Chapter End Notes

Here's another chapter. It's been delayed due to a certain Owl House project. Feel free to comment and post your opinions.

Ruins of Umbracor

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They traveled another day, through the parched Plains that made up the southwestern edge of the former Scorpion Country. The vehicle was cramped, but he didn't mind. Even the fact that he had to share space with Hordak didn't matter much now. He was with his wife, and he had fallen in love with her all over again. He felt butterflies in his stomach, he wanted to dance and kiss his beloved. He might not get all those lost years back, but at least he would be with her again. He would spend the rest of his life with her. Could anything matter now? He knew she was incredibly happy about it, but he could also see that something was bothering her. She didn't say what she was worried about, and he didn't want to push her, at least not until he had a better opportunity.

Tirin stood next to them, hunched up a little, staring at the horizon with fear. He had done her in, she was one of those people you couldn't help but like. She was nice, though shy. The world scared her, but at the same time she wanted to face it. It seemed that she didn't like violence, but at the same time she knew how to fight. She was a walking contradiction. This also applied to the fact that she belonged to the same civilization, if that's Azlantii could be called civilized, that had enslaved his wife, but it was thanks to this girl that she was able to free herself. Angela had said that she was as close to her as a daughter, so maybe he should think of her that way, at least a little. He wasn't sure how Glimmer would react to the fact that he had someone like a sister. She shouldn't reject her, because after all she was a good girl, and Tirin seemed very nice too. Besides, the Azlantean would be accompanying her mother, whom she thought she had

lost, so it would be hard for her to be angry at her in such a situation.

He had a bit more trouble with the ancient AI that had put on a body. He knew what her… mother had almost done. He didn't know much about artificial intelligences. He had no idea if they inherited their parents' personality in some way, he hoped they didn't… Heart Gift seemed quite nice, and to tell the truth, she didn't inspire fear at all. She seemed a bit awkward and acted as if the whole world fascinated her. There was something quite charming about it. He had never seen anyone who could be so delighted by the sight of a beetle crawling on his hand. Besides, she had helped them escape from that underground shelter, or whatever it was, so she deserved a little trust.

The area began to become more and more forested. However, the trees looked strange, as if unhealthy. They were short and twisted, full of thorns. It was normal, actually, but still... Well, he had read quite a bit about this place. Supposedly, the magic used here left its mark on this place. It had never been properly investigated. Everyone was too ashamed of what had happened here. Throughout Etheria's long history, the events of the War of the Sorcerers seemed to be one of the darkest, if not the darkest. Now he wondered if Shadow Weaver would have come here to train if it hadn't happened. From what he had heard, she would have liked it here. Despite the fact that the sorcerers who studied here were known as iconoclasts, they were much more open to new knowledge and often dangerous experiments. It was said that they tried to reach beyond Etheria and discover other dimensions It was once widely believed that they had never succeeded because it was impossible to reach other worlds, if they existed at all, but long before their planet was extracted from Despondos, he had witnessed that this was not the case. Some said that the being Shadow Weaver had summoned was simply a strange entity made of pure magic, but he knew better. He could sense its unfathomable intelligence and evil. Few believed him, and he did not want to delve into such dark topics, there was no reason for it anyway… Until it turned out that the dark magic used

by his former teacher had led to the greatest defeat of the rebellion…

At last they reached the Basin where Umbracor was supposed to be . At first glance they recognized how different it was from Mystacor. Despite all these centuries, the most important structure of the college survived. This was understandable, because the college was built of living wood. Thousands of branches intertwined together to create a huge dome, resembling an anthill or a termite mound, full of corridors and rooms. He had never thought that a structure made of living plants could cause such anxiety. The companions also They stopped, and looked at the entire structure, shocked by its vastness But he was shaken by something that the Others were unaware of, with one exception… Hordak was the first to speak..

„It resembles the Beast Island, only it is made of living metal, and this is wood, although it is still alive. I do not like it very much, do you have any maps of this place? Although I am not sure if they will be up to date... The island could change From day to day...„ He said gloomily, and looked at him, and the others followed his gaze, asking a silent question. He needed a moment, To get himself under control, and then he said.

„I'll be fine, it's not Beast Island, it's just a bit similar, but it's not much smaller than the group that's waiting for us there.„ He tried to sound as composed as possible, but then Ireanis spoke up.

„You're right, on The Beast Island there were probably only large beasts like dinosaurs, but here I can sense gaps between worlds leading to other planes, and what about more evil ones, you know Hell and so on, so it must be much worse than on your island.„ she said which with excitement like a child going on a trip, it didn't bode well for their trip.

"I think you mentioned Hell... It's not a nice place, is it?" Casta asked, and the silver-haired Sorceress waved her hand and said.

„It's no problem, all you need is the right spells, especially the magic of unsummoning... They taught you that in school, right? That Mystacor of yours seemed like a pretty good school, they dealt with that Vrock I summoned really quickly.„ she said, still with joyful enthusiasm. None of the members of the expedition shared that feeling, except maybe Heart Gift , who clearly didn't understand the context.

„Don't be afraid, Captain... „ Tonado said, turning to Angela with an absolutely serious face. „I will go ahead, and I will be the first to fall victim to any dark spells that any demons we meet will cast. „ Despite his and their large size, there was no doubt in their minds that he would be the first to throw himself into battle. Angela looked at him seriously and said.

„I'm glad you're so brave, my first officer, but I think it would be best if nothing happened to you, because who would I replace you with? „ she said and he had the impression that Tonado wanted to say something, but he changed his mind and just nodded.

So they stopped in front of the monstrous structure to consider their next actions. They could see the remains of the outer structures, most of them ruined or swallowed by nature, but not all of them. They stopped at a squat tower about two stories high, and there was enough room for everyone. She wasn't sure what the building was for, she wasn't an expert in architecture and neither was her brother, in fact she found it a very boring field of study. As they entered, she saw Angela standing next to her brother, and their hands gently touched. She resisted the urge to smile at the sight. She was very happy for her brother. She noticed that both girls, Tirin and Heart Gift, were standing next to each other, and the AI was asking the girl in the biosuit something, who answered her clearly embarrassed, but at the same time pleased. She smiled at the sight. Although she had never been interested in such matters, it was nice to be surrounded by so much love. And then she was standing next to

her. On one side was Ireanis, and on the other was Hordak, definitely not the company she wanted, but she wasn't going to complain now. So she sighed and simply asked.

„Did Shadow Weaver give you a map or something?”

The sorceress looked around as if searching for the person the question was directed at, until she finally realized it was her. She reached into her bag and pulled out several sheets of paper, waving them in their faces.

„Shadow Weaver gave me a few things and told me to show them to you. Actually, there's not much of it.„ she handed them the materials. They were all written in Shadow Weaver's neat handwriting, how on Etheria was she able to write so beautifully with such claws? It bordered on obsession. Her handwriting was... Characteristic, like most college in school. Although some people complained that it was hard to read what she wrote, it only took a little effort to understand everything...

The documents showed sketches of Umbracor, surprisingly consistent with what they saw when they got here. She drew a map, although very imprecise and rather illustrative, which was supposed to lead them to the place, Where Stelarium was located ... She couldn't be sure how much they were true to the facts, but she had to admit that it was impressive that she managed to draw it all from memory, because after all, she had not had access to their libraries since her stay in Mystacor, And that was over thirty-five years ago. Hordak, seeing this, grimaced and said.

"How is that supposed to help us explore this place?" he said, and then Mikach said.

„It's always better than nothing, but I managed to find some old descriptions of the place in Lance and George's library and I made a map based on them too, so using both of them we might be able to find the right way relatively quickly. Is there anything else here?”

„A list of possible threats we might encounter here, as well as a description from the Stelarium itself, along with a way to use it. And considerations on how to open the gate to the vault, or observatory, where it should be stored.„ she explained to her brother, looking through the heavily crumpled papers. Some of them had traces of something sweet and sticky... Some kind of drink? She looked askance at the sorceress Saihe, who was drinking something orange and smelling of floor cleaner...

„Well, that's pretty good, anyway, we know where to start. But what dangers is she talking about?„ her brother asked. She frowned and told him what it said.

„She writes about bearded devils, shadow demons and especially about some Velstracs and daemons. How do they differ from demons?„ Feeling a headache Since when did the World become so complicated? Once the problem was what new equipment Hordak would invent, And now they had to deal with terrible beings from other dimensions. She was the chief sorcerer of Mystacor and should know everything related to magic, but it turned out that she knew very little. Saihe Sorceress smiled and said.

„Oh yeah, there's a big difference. Daemons are there to fuck you up, and Demons are there to fuck you to death. Either way, you should shoot before you ask questions... It always works.”

She sighed, not really liking what she heard, and then Angela asked.

„Could you explain to me what's going on with these schools? Why is this place so ruined?”

She looked at her in surprise.

„But you were there then.... I forgot that you lost your memories. You know, about these things. „ she rubbed her health, embarrassed by the awkwardness of what she was saying.

„Maybe I'll tell you everything?„ Mikach said, smiling gently, and she didn’t protested. Her brother knew the whole story as well as she did, and it was probably better that he explained everything to his wife and companions. Hordak leaned back against the wall, and Heart Gift knelt on the ground, staring at the former Prince Consort like a kindergarten child at a teacher. Tirin sat down next to her and listened, but she looked a bit more relaxed than before, clearly feeling good with a roof over her head. Mikah took a deep breath and began to speak in the calm voice that had convinced so many to support the rebellion during the war.

„Once, when our planet was just rebuilding after the chaos that came after the First Ones left it the role of sorcerers in Etherian society was very significant, especially since we had lost most of our technical knowledge by then, and it took many centuries to regain it. In the beginning there were numerous and small schools of sorcerers, many trying to teach on a master and apprentice basis, but more and more were needed and some Princesses became interested in ensuring that teaching on their lands was conducted in a controlled manner, without dozens of schools teaching contradictory and unproven theories. Eventually, three schools were created, each created by different rulers. So the ruler of Brightmoon, not you, but one of your predecessors, created Mystacor, the ruler of Salinea created Arkancor on one of the islands , and the ruler of Centimeni , the Country Of Scorpions, provided funds for the creation of Umbracor. The schools enjoyed great independence, and each of them was practically an independent kingdom. After all, most of the sorcerers settled in these Three places, and most of the magical power that did not depend on the princesses was in their hands. However, if you know the map of our planet, you know that these colleges were relatively close to each other, and a large part of Etheria was beyond their immediate reach. As you know, people always want more, and although at first all the colleges focused on educating the next generations of sorcerers, but after some time the leaders of specific colleges began to compete with each other. Differences in worldviews also came to this.„ Micah finished, and then she interrupted

„Yes! Mystacor focused on personal growth, Arcanacor taught about magical theory, and Umbracor encouraged questioning the rules and seeking new discoveries.„ she explained from the house but her brother motioned for her to speak and began to explain.

„It's not quite like that. Mystacor focused on making magic useful to people. Arcanacor, on the other hand, studied the rules that governed the arcane arts. Some say that Umbracor taught that power is the most important thing... „ when he said that, she grimaced and added.

„ I think we know now why Shadow Weaver was so interested in this place.„ she said but Mikah shook his head.

„It's not like that. As you know, Umbracor was the school that was blamed for the tragedy that happened later. It seems to me that they were rather looking for the truth, among the myths and lies that the others believed in... In a way, it's a pity that they fell, because maybe we would have known in advance who the First Ones really were, and maybe we would have found another way to get out of Despondos, so as not to fall into Horde Prime's grasp ... Or at least we would have been better prepared for the arrival of the Horde... I guess it doesn't matter now... In any case, tensions were growing, and you have to know that the main source of power of all schools were their students. However, the number of people with a talent for magic is always very limited. So they tried to convince more and more Princesses to allow only them to recruit students to their schools. Many did not agree to this, so the Leaders ruling all magic schools tried to influence it, to remove those who were inconvenient. Soon they also began to fight among themselves, and since the Magic of the sorcerers was the most powerful power available on our planet at that time, excluding of course the Powers of the Princesses... That is why the clashes were brutal and bloody. Soon some of the rulers also joined these fights, to gain the support of the leaders of all schools. only deepening the chaos. The conflict escalated. There were more and more victims and more and more terrible magic was used, although I have the impression that it was still not much compared to what the sorcerers from outside our world

use... It came to a stalemate, and no one could gain the upper hand. In the end, however, it was supposedly Umbracor who did something terrible. They unleashed a terrible power and destroyed Arkanacor . All that was left after him was the island of black stone... Thousands died, and then all the princesses formed an alliance, even the ruler of the Scorpions, who until then had patronized Umbracor, and set out to besiege this school. It is said that the siege lasted thre years, and many died, including three Princesses, but slowly they managed to gain the upper hand because the forces of the sorcerers from this place were depleting, and they also managed to gain the sorcerers from Mystacor, who agreed to submit absolutely to the rule of the Princesses, and were supported by the sorcerers from the destroyed Arkanacor. The fighting continued for a while,, until the supposedly highest sorcerers of Umbracor tried to use dark magic once more, but this time they failed and the entire college was cursed. Some time later the leaders of Mystacor swore complete neutrality and that they would never again interfere in politics. In the meantime, these ruins were considered a cursed place and forever abandoned. Eventually they were forgotten, although I have the impression that it was mainly because of the shame of the war of the sorcerers. So in this way only one college remained, which as we all know did not discover the most important mysteries of our planet.”

Everyone was silent for a moment until finally Ireanis spoke.

“Our University of Magaambya has existed for four thousand years, and nothing so terrible has ever happened there.„ Saihe woman smiled and hid the bag of crisps she was eating during the story. She felt a surge of strange patriotism, because she felt that someone had insulted her university, and for which she could not agree.

„But you don't teach there anymore, and I don't think it's just because it's gone...”

And in that moment, a change came over Ireanis' eyes. Her face hardened, the goofy smile disappeared, and there was a note of

steel in her voice.

„What do you know about my life. I fought creatures more terrible than what you met there in the underground. It's just that at some point everyone breaks. If you met someone like Ashaq the Annihilator, we will see how much is left without your courage and values."

They finally saw in her who she once was, or perhaps who she truly was, deep in her heart. She decided, won't you look at her like a drunken idiot...

"Who was this Ashaq , and is there a chance we might meet her someday?" Hordak asked, and Ireanis hesitated.

„I once thought it was destroyed along with the Lost Golarion , but then I was almost certain that I sensed it. It was an ancient dragon that became a vampire, and what it might be like now, I have no idea."

And again there was silence. It was broken by the Queen.

„Well, we can only hope she won't want to go to those ruins..."

Lady Sorrowflame didn't need to breathe, but she still took in the air saturated with the smell of death into her dead lungs. A great battle had once been fought here, terrible and magnificent together. Thousands had died here, and it had been caused by the Dark powers. She knew who could be the perpetrator of this massacre, and she smiled to herself, feeling a certain gratitude towards Shadow Weaver. From what she had heard, this place was cut off from magic, although not as much as you would like that of the former empire of Horde Prime ... But now the winds of magic blew here, and the shadow of death itself fell on this place. Thousands of souls wanted Vengeance on those who had taken their lives or abandoned them here, but it had no meaning to her anyway. She had not come here to bring Justice and calm the dead, but to enslave them. She had not led the legions of the

dead for a long time, for millennia, but perhaps the time had come to return to the old ways. She stood naked with her arms spread wide and sang an incantation of awakening. The dead here were easier to tame than she had expected, but that was probably a trait of all the inhabitants of this place., after all the Etherians had opposed Horde Prime himself , but he was just a mad mortal tyrant, and she was an Annihilator, chosen by Dahak himself, one of the greatest necromancers in the known part of the Galaxy, so no matter how much they resisted their Will had to be broken. She heard the screams of thousands of angry Souls. That was probably why she didn't hear what was approaching her behind her. She felt a cold blade right next to her throat.

„Move and you die a second time.„ said a hoarse voice. She only smiled and replied.

„Even if you were able to do it, which you probably believe you are, you wouldn't do it because you would have already tried... So please, let's stop with the empty threats.”

For a moment she still felt the steel at her neck until her interlocutor, because it was probably a woman, judging by her voice, thought better of it and took the blade away from her throat. Then she turned around and for perhaps the first time in a thousand years she was surprised.

„Another one? That's interesting, the Lord Admiral will be really surprised... „She said looking at the girl. She had a scar on her cheeks, imitating a smile, she rather doubted and the exhibition did it to itself. Her eyes are metal and her hair is black like Catra's, but humanly straight. All of her limbs were replaced with prosthetics, and not ordinary cybernetic ones, but wonderful artifacts... She had already gotten one of these, but it was stolen and from what she heard it belonged to that girl who ran away. Who is person she was talking to? Next to her stood a female android, her body covered in scars that looked surprisingly familiar.It was all very interesting, and her scientist soul was purring happily.

„But how should I address you?„ she said, and the Girl replied in a hoarse voice.

„ My name is Commander Despara. By the Will of Lord Protector Felix Antares , I am his second in command, and therefore your superior. You are, I presume, Lady Sorrowflame.„ The girl said, and she smiled at her, showing her black fangs.

„That's what they call me...„ She said, but then Despara added.

„But your name is really Ashaq The Annihilator’”

Hearing these words, she felt curious. For hundreds of years, few people had addressed her by that name, it was almost as valuable as her God. Even the Lord Admiral did not know it.

„I see that you are a well-informed person. Now that we have the greetings behind us, I would like to know what it is that you are looking for. „ She asked, carefully looking at herself and her interlocutor.

„It depends on how much you know about everything that's going on around you. You're an ancient dragon, one of the few survivors of the lost Golarion. You know about the First Ones... But you don't know what they did... Although, as I can see, you probably already know something... „ she tilted her head, looking at her closely. She clenched her teeth angrily. She hadn't expected her emotions to be so visible on her face. She didn't like losing control of herself, On the other hand, in this case she had the right to do so, for what happened to her... For someone who devoted his entire life, and unlife, to serving God, his death was a terrible experience, actually understandable for people who hadn't experienced it.

„I've heard some suggestions, but you're going to a certain place because the evidence will be waiting for me there.”

The cat girl nodded and said.

„ You can believe me or not, It's all true, but then again... Why would you believe the word of someone you've just met? I wouldn't believe myself. So go where you're going, and find out the truth. Just tell me who told you all this...

She wondered for a moment if she should be loyal to Lady Cala and the rest… But if they claimed to be on the side they said they were on, then they should be happy to have a new ally, especially someone who claimed to be the Lord Admiral's right hand. But she should inform Lady Ka about everything. She owed her enough, at least to warn her that the situation in the high command had changed dramatically.

„She introduced herself as Lady Cala, but her real name is Calamity ... I don't know if it will be easy for you to find her, but if you manage to... „ she didn't finish because her interlocutor took out a small object that emanated such great power that Even She had to squint. She saw first a miniature map of the Galaxy, then planets, and the girl stared at its image for a moment, then she cut the air with her fingers, and together with her companion she walked into interdimensional space . In the meantime, she looked at the plain, where the dead were crowded. She smiled, because in this way she gained enormous strength, which could support Antares' plans, and above all, her plans, if necessary. She took on her true form, spread her wings and rose into the air towards the ruins of Umbracor.

Chapter End Notes

Ruins of Umbracor

Entering the Path of the Shadows

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Entering the Path of the Shadows.

She woke up, and for a brief moment she was sure that she was a young woman again, just waiting to get out of the place she had lived. It was only after a moment that it dawned on her that she had already reached middle age, and had essentially ruined her life, as well as the lives of many people she had met over the years.

She received, or rather took over the chamber of one of the higher officials. She did not intend to live in her mother's rooms, in fact she did not want to take her position, at least not really. Yes, she needed her power, to implement her plans, as well as the plans of Creeping Chaos but she never wanted to rule over her countrymen. If only she could, she would abandon this place, and never return here, but unfortunately she had to stay here for some time, and she would probably have to use the power of the Islands of Sorrow to achieve what she intended to do. Despite everything, a part of her soul was happy with what she had done. Perhaps if she had not met Silentscream, she would not have been so determined to carry out a coup d'état, but after seeing how her niece was treated, she decided that Whispering Mist deserved everything she had done to her.

She didn't ask for servants, because she knew that after her demonstration, almost none of them would work of their own free will, they would have to be wooed first, and even then there was little chance they would agree to come in, but that didn't matter to her anyway. She could manage without servants, there wasn't much to do... She had prepared everything in advance.

She boiled a kettle of water for tea and unpacked the food she had received from the cultists. She knew she would have to take some more supplies, especially those that could be stored for a long time. It would also be useful to take some money. Money made of silver and gold, because where she went, none of the currencies available here would matter, and for some unknown reason, gold was valued everywhere, as was silver. Fortunately, she had access to the entire Yago clan treasury, so getting money wouldn't be a problem. It would be worse with someone to help her on her journey. She guessed that she would find herself in a alien world in a completely strange place and may not have contact with civilization for a long time. Not to mention that she might not know the customs there, so it might be difficult for her to hire someone to help. She didn't know who this Claudia was, and she didn't know if finding her would be difficult... She would have to do something about it... She already had a few ideas, but she wasn't sure which ones she should implement.

As she was thinking this, Storm Heart entered the room, watching her for a moment as she stood in the doorway. They hadn't spoken yesterday, she wasn't sure how the Storm Warden would react to the coup d'état. She had forbidden her to let her in before dawn, because she needed to get some sleep, and she also preferred for the woman to calm down a bit, but she was glad she had come now. After a moment, the warrior said in a hard and cold voice.

„Just tell me one thing, did you and Midnight mask plan this from the beginning?„ She looked at her sharply, and she answered immediately, so that her sister wouldn't think she was trying to lie to her.

„ I did. From the very beginning when I arrived at our embassy, I planned to do something similar, although I was still considering possible solutions. However, Midnight Mask was not privy to anything, she is simply predictable. What is she doing now?”

„She forces everyone to swear allegiance to you, and also arrests those she doesn't think are loyal enough.. In addition, she ordered

an announcement on the streets that you are the new leader of the clans and also notified the other leaders, who immediately sent assurances of subordination, so I guess everything is fine, as much as it can be after a coup d'état. „ Stormheart explained in a voice as if she was giving a report. But in her eyes you can see something she hasn't seen before. Uncertainty or maybe gratitude.

„What do you think about all this, about what I've done, and also what do you think I'm going to do?”

The Storm Warden blinked a few times. Asking others for their opinions was not the way her family managed their subordinates … It was only after a long moment that Stormheart spoke.

„I am... I am grateful that ... you did something for my daughter. I am not sure how much it will matter now, but at least my mother will understand what she did to her. You do not know how hard it was for her... A child out of wedlock, with a mother like me... It was a double burden. She was always despised, but all those who were my enemies could hurt her with impunity, at least to some extent. Now... Her position is still uncertain, but at least you distinguished yourself, for better or for worse. Of course, everything that has happened to her so far is your fault...„ her sister looked at her coldly, and she did not answer, because she knew well that her sister was right. „As for your plans, I cannot predict them. I am sure that you are planning something. You have always been planning something. I can only hope that all of us will not have to pay for all of this „ she looked at her for a moment longer, and then she answered her.

"I hope it won't cost you much, but I can't guarantee it... Now we're all pawns in the game of a beings older and more powerful than we imagine..." She said with absolute sincerity, and Stormheart sighed heavily.

"People like me will always be someone's pawns, we can only hope that the players didn't decide to sacrifice them at the first opportunity... And I'm not sure I can trust you enough to believe

that you would do that to me." She said, and now she saw how overwhelmed and tired her sister was from everything she had been through. And probably before it was all over, many more terrible things would happen. They could only hope that they would manage to deal with it all... and they will not fall into the darkness that was gathering around them.

"I am a pawn to , there is no doubt about it my dear... But remember that even Pawns can make a move against the will of their masters... Even if it costs you a terrible price... But there is always a price to pay..." she said and smiled at Stormheart and for the first time in a hundred years of her life she felt truly close to her sister. She took her hand and said.

"We will meet again, in this life. I need your help, and I will probably ask for it soon. Be ready and Train your storm riders." She said and hugged Stormheart, then left. She had one more place to go before she enter the Path of Shadows.

Her mother had brought herself to the chapel, or rather hid there. It was pointless, because no one could see her, nor she anyone… Except for the terrible fiend, Silentscream and of course herself. As soon as she saw her, Whispering Mist moved towards her with fury in her eyes. She moved her hand, and shadow tentacles grabbed the woman. Despite the fact that she was old and sick, she knew that she shouldn't underestimate her. From her own example, she understood that someone like her mother could still be deadly dangerous. After all, she had spent her entire life spinning Intrigues and murdering rivals.

„And you still dare to show up here, you traitor. Viper! You've deceived everyone! You've betrayed your entire family. If I had known that I would give birth to such a vile spawn, I would have smashed your head long ago...„ She shouted at her with a hissing voice, but she didn't let her continue speaking.

„At least have some honor to accept your defeat. You only got what you deserved. Actually, I felt disappointed. I never expected you to behave decently, but at least you could have been a little more reasonable, more cunning. If you were as smart as you always wanted to be, you would have at least tried to hide your anger, and somehow placate me, lull my vigilance... Well , you found yourself in the place you are by your own will... And be nice to Silentscream, or you will starve. And don't try any tricks, because the creature I summoned will be watching you, if it thinks you are up to something, then that is your miserable fate.„ She said and left her, hoping forever.

The temple of the spider was an impressive structure, even on the scale of what she had seen in the rest of the Galaxy, and it was certainly the largest temple on all of Etheria… Almost certainly, because even she had no idea what the darkest corners of this planet hid. It had probably been significantly damaged during Horde Prime's brief occupation, but it had been one of the first places to be rebuilt… Or maybe the madman had simply remade it in his image now… She had no idea what was considered worse. She hadn't been here since... leaving the island, and she felt a strange, overwhelming feeling, as if she had gone back in time... As if she were a gloomy acolyte again, who would one day become a high priestess. She had never had much faith in her heart, even after she had been brought back to life, and then she had stood before the face of God, although Nyarlathotep was not a God that even the most faithful worshippers wanted to stand before. Due to her job as Lady Cala's steward, she had to visit the temple a few times, but she never paid much attention to it. After all these years, she could barely remember How to talk to the priests... Oh well, that wouldn't last long.

However, before she entered the temple, Silentscream was waiting for her at the gate . She grimaced at the sight, because she thought the girl should have kept a closer eye on her grandmother, because this woman could be plotting something even now, but she wasn't going to scold the girl, because she had

already been through a lot during the few years she had been in this world

„Thank you, auntie... For everything you've done.„ The girl said, and she smiled at her sourly.

"You're welcome," she said with bitterness in her voice, and then moved on, but this would have stopped her and asked.

„How did you actually come into the world? From what I understand, your father was banished from this place about seventy years ago… And you're certainly not that old…”

Silentscream lowered her head and said.

„During the war, pirates abounded. The Storm Warden convinced the First Mother to take up the hunt for pirates. But she wasn't the only one hunting them. One of the Corsairs hired by the ruler of Salinea also took part in it. As you can imagine, it was my father. During the fight with one of the most dangerous pirates, Iathem of the dead eyes, they joined forces and defeated him. Only they knew the truth that they were once lovers. During the celebration... They spent the night together... and that's how I came into being. The ruler was furious, but my mother promised Absolute obedience, In exchange for letting me live. Whispering Mist not only agreed, but even allowed me to serve at the Palace with my mother… „ the girl explained, and she smiled sadly at her and said.

„Listen to me, Leave this place. On this planet, and even in the whole universe, There are many beautiful and wonderful places. You can visit any of them. You are still young, and not tied to anyone, so the world is open to you, do not make the same mistake as we all did. Don't let loyalty to your family or the lust for power cause you to suffer the same fate as us.„ She said, smiling at the girl as friendly as someone with her appearance could. Silentscream lowered her eyes and said quietly

„Then I would have to abandon my grandmother... Only you and I can see her, and only somewhere does she see you, apart from that monster, of course.”

“Damn, I got this girl stuck taking care of one of the nastiest people on the entire planet.” she thought, and sighed heavily.

“Then leave her, or take her with you, if that's what you want, but it's better not to stay here, it's best if she somehow goes to Absalom Station, it's the safest place in the whole galaxy, and you'll see more wonders there than you can imagine. I've only been there once, but I have to say it was wonderful.„ she said, and her niece thought about it and nodded period

„I will consider your words aunty„ Said Silentscream and she headed towards the temple.

The interior was truly impressive. To build such a huge structure only from darkwood was an extraordinary feat. She would see the red Lacquer or nacre representations of the history of their nation, as well as their divine patroness, the Spider. All the priests and the surroundings looked at her with slight fear, probably because of what she had done in the throne room. Now they probably saw her as the chosen one of their goddess, and at the same time someone cursed and tainted by foreign influences, so they had no idea how they should treat her. She was a bit ashamed of the act she had to act out, although on the other hand, it wasn't such a big lie. After all, she had summoned one of the Avatars of Atlach-Nacha ... Pacting with the Great Old One was never easy, but the Weaver Between Worlds was one of the most rational, but she still suspected that she was only able to survive this agreement because she had the support of the Creeping Chaos. But now she had to be careful not to end up on the cursed plateau of Leng. There, it might turn out that this ancient entity might want to repay a debt she owed, and she already had too many.. Now, however, she needed the priests' help, or at least one place to be made available.

The Supreme Spinner stood in front of the Great Altar resembling a spider, for what else could it resemble? Once this position had been her destiny, but long ago She had already left this path and chosen the path that led her into darkness. The woman in the mask turned towards her, but Her gaze was hard, but not defiant either, which meant that the Spinner had some sense after all.

„What are your wishes, ruler of the clans…" she asked, appraising her with her eyes.

„Take me to the vaults. „ she ordered without even explaining what exactly she meant, after all, for a very long time the main task of the spinners was to serve the clans. Once they supposedly had more power, and could even decide who would be the head of the clan, but they quickly threw it in and it was cut short, after all the leaders of her people did not need competition, or someone to judge them. The woman turned her head to the side, as if she was interested in her words, and then said.

„For many years, no one has looked into that place, except for the custodians and the Spinners, the heads of the clans were usually not interested in the past. Usually, we advised them against it, because many of the things hidden there have the Stain of heresy, so it would be better if it did not touch those Who govern us."

She smiled when she heard these words, and it was not a pleasant smile, and she said

„Well, I'm a bit of a heretic myself, so this is probably the right place for someone like me, don't you think? „ she tried to sound gentle, but also firm. Spinner didn't react when she smiled, and most people didn't feel comfortable in her company when they saw her true face.

„Indeed, you are right. Someone like you is in no danger there. she replied thoughtfully. Then she gave her a sign to go with her. She did so, but she did not stop being vigilant, because she did not trust the Priestess, or, to tell the truth, anyone present here. She knew that they were afraid of her, but she also aroused in

them... Disgust? That was not the right word, maybe rather Holy Wrath... They were not sure if she was the chosen one of their goddess, or perhaps a heretic and a fraud... Unfortunately, she was neither one nor the other... She was something much worse.

The spinner went with her, accompanied by two guards called custodians. They were armed only with iron-tipped stafs, because that was all the clan rulers allowed, but even if they had modern weapons it didn't matter. She was prepared, and in such a situation few were able to cope with her, not in these times. The richly inlaid walls of the tunnels reminded her of Castle Grayskull. The seat of the family whose name Lady Cala used had a huge number of underground corridors, which she explored for some time, although she didn't discover too many secrets there, at least not those important to. They had only one electric lantern, but it gave enough light, especially since her people could see well in dim light. The higher rooms were almost certainly storage rooms, because she could see that they were often used, and looking into some of the doors she passed, she saw that there were many candles or incense inserts there. However, the further they went, the less frequented the corridors were, and many doors looked as if they were opened once every few years. She had always been drawn to mysteries, and now she could barely resist the urge to order it to stop and show her what was inside. She didn’t have time for that. Eventually they reached the end of the corridor, where there was a door made of black wood and mother of pearl, with a bas-relief in the shape of a Great Spider; she had to admit that her people were quite monothematic. Spinner led her to the door, and placing her hand on it, whispered a few words, and then it opened. She thought for a moment; she knew that spider priests used magic, although they weren’t very good at it, but once it had been ordinary sorcerous magic, but now, with the destruction of the Heart, they might have gained access to some form of magic from the gods, which could be problematic if they chose to oppose it. But nothing of the sort happened, and the priestess led her into the vast room. There were many sculptures here , extremely old, several of them even had tablets inscribed with symbols from the language of the First Ones, as if they had

been taken from some exhibition or museum. She shivered with an indefinable fear, then looked around further and sucked in a hiss. She saw a statue, what you had depicted a person with a face half light, half dark. One was smiling, the other was furious. She knew Who this being was, she had heard of it, and even seen its priests of Carurystal. Nethys, the God of magic and secrets with the dual nature of savior and destroyer. She remembered the bas-relief she had just seen, and now she understood Who the being her countrymen worshipped was in fact.

„Welcome to the Vault, or rather the archive. „ said the priestess, and she fell away.

„The Archives of Nethys ... „ She said and saw the priestess smiling under her veil, then pointed to a large obsidian mirror. She felt a pang of Uneasiness as the priestess led her before it. After all, she had very logical reasons for not liking mirrors, or at least the mystical ones that could hide Eldritch Beings behind them.

"This is the path of shadows, for it is the path you sought, truth.„ said Spinner, and she turned to her, narrowed her eyes and asked.

 How did you know?„ Her deep distrust of everyone suddenly ignited with a black flame.

„We've been notified of what you might be looking for. Now we'll leave you alone, which is probably almost the case, right?"

She couldn't deny it, she needed privacy to do what she wanted, but now she felt uneasy . Was this a trap? Even if it was, she still had to take this path to follow the orders of this treacherous sorcerer… She sighed and stood in front of the mirror and gently touched it with her hand.

„Greetings! Come!„ she heard a double voice, one gentle the other furious. You felt confused comma and looked around.

„No there is no there is, I am everywhere. „ the voice rang out again. She sighed, because she had no time for this type of discussion.

„Tell me who you are and what you want.„ She exclaimed, irritated.

„You don't recognize me?... How can you not know what your goddess is.„ said the dual voice and she almost laughed. The last thing she needed right now was to talk to the goddess worshiped by her people.

„I serve another being, more terrible and powerful than anything in the world.„ she warned, although from what she knew, there was a rather small chance that Nyarlathotep would aid her. Although it was an external God, like everyone else, it avoided the islands as a mediator of conflicts with higher beings... She could only hope that the spider would also want to avoid an unnecessary clash.

„We know that... It's obvious. We don't want to hurt you... It's a waste of our power!„ the double voice shouted. It must be admitted that it made the whole conversation exceptionally tiring...

„So, leave me alone, because I have an important mission to accomplish, and from what I know it 's in your best interest for me to succeed.„ she said in a tired voice, she was not in the mood to argue with gods and similar beings.

„But are you sure that these are your true goals? You always want power!„ the voice called. She smiled and said.

„Yes, I've always wanted her, but not now. I want food...„ and at that moment she hesitated, because she wasn't sure what she really wanted. Did she want to be bought, forgivenes? But her daughters, the adopted ones, would never forgive her, that's exactly what they told her... And besides, she brought someone like Calamity here . Did she want to Save the world? She had tried once before, a long time ago. When she had performed the ritual, she had dreamed of being a hero, but in reality, her intentions weren't pure then. She wanted to be admired, worshiped, like a savior... It was a very selfish desire. So she sighed and said.

„All I want now is to save my daughter from the terrible fate that may await her, so that she doesn't repeat my mistakes. She said, and then heard a double laugh.

„Really? If this is true, then the Gate will be here soon, But be careful, because you must prove your righteousness. Otherwise, you will die miserably! „ said the Voice, And she sighed and went to the mirror. She touched its surface and her hand disappeared inside. It was something she should have expected... She thought about it, Spinner had probably prepared everything in advance, waiting for this to appear. The cunning priestess knew that he would appear here, or perhaps the God of magic had told her everything. Now it did not matter much. She took a deep breath and entered the darkness...

Chapter End Notes

Here's another chapter. Nethys is in a state between base form and spider form. Feel free to comment...

Surrounded by darkness

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

These corridors were a bit too low for her, as were for Hordak , who was cowering and growling angrily. Of course, she still had wings, which were relatively inflexible due to the metal frame... Fortunately, she had her mask, so at least she had no problem breathing. The wings turned out to be useful anyway. Although she could no longer fly, they still allowed her to glide and made longer jumps easier. Thanks to this, they managed to cross several crevices that had formed in the structure of the former college. The first one was relatively small, so her husband gave her a rope, and then two more, thanks to which they opened a simple rope bridge that they could cross. The exception was Hordak, whose armor was of course too heavy, so he simply had to jump over it, as she did. She silently wished he would trip and break his neck, but that didn't happen. Tirin had to catch Hear Gift, who after passing kindled curiously leaned over the edge and almost fell. Well, after all, she had had this body for a few days, and she probably wasn't used to it, or to what capabilities it had. Worse, Castaspella from Ireanis had to do the same, when the silver-haired sorceress looked into some shaft, and started looking for someone. This expedition had many more dangers than Miss... Shadow Weaver had expected.

The second time she could use her wings was when they reached the place where the spiral staircase should have been. The branches here began to grow chaotically and formed a tangle covered with thorns.. There was only one narrow opening that led to the very bottom.

„I think the spells controlling the growth of these plants slowly started to fall here, I just hope nothing happens when I do

something…„ and she jumped down. As soon as she did, she heard her husband's frightened scream, but it was too late. She spread her wings and landed safely, although she had to maneuver between the branches. However, she had learned to glide quite well on what was left of her wings, so she managed.

When she got to the bottom, everything was covered in darkness. She summoned a solar flare, and wanted to look around, but then she heard the sound of breaking branches, and Hordak landed next to her. She stopped herself from gnashing her teeth. Right after him, descending with some spell, was Ireanis, who smiled at her.

„Mikach! I think your wife is safe and sound, and I'm almost certain she didn't break anything!„ the sorceress called up. In the meantime, she looked around the room, but there was nothing special here except for the corridor that led deeper into the building. After a moment, her husband landed right next to her. She wanted to greet him, but then she heard a voice.

„Please, I've been trapped here for ages, Please help me!„ and they saw a middle-aged woman, dirty and dressed in rags, who was walking towards them. Then Ireanis smiled and cast a spell in her direction, and Hordak a second later shot where the sorceress had cast the spell Without thinking, she also joined the attack.. Only Mikach watched everything with his mouth open and eyes in horror. However, when the flashes of the spell exposure faded, they saw a terrible monster, it had a horned head and a body covered with a green shell, whose upper ends looked like pincers, which made the middle, almost human hands seem grotesquely tiny.

„And this is Glabrezu, Shadow Weaver didn't mention them...„ Ireanis said thoughtfully and began to prepare another spell. At this time Hordak stepped forward, covering them, and fired again, this time however the demon dodged and attacked him with its pincers. One of them clamped on the armor, which creaked under the pressure. She cursed very nastily, because she didn't like what she was about to do, but she had no choice. So she jumped

behind the creature, and threw a frost Bolt at its back from close range, which burned another hole in the creature's armor. The elven sorceress's magic bolts hit the creature's snout, which roared and cast a spell at her. Suddenly she forgot where she was and who the people around her. She didn't know what to do and who her enemy was. She started shooting blindly in terror not knowing who she was fighting. She heard someone hit, a short broken groan and then her senses returned and she saw her husband holding his arm, his face twisted in pain.

„ I... I'm sorry!„ she said, but Mikach just waved his hand as if it was nothing important and cast a spell at the creature, which was no longer holding Hordak, as its pincers were shattered, probably thanks to the clone's power armor. A powerful energy beam pierced the demon through and through, and then she began firing at it at close range until the creature finally fell and dissolved in a cloud of stinking black smoke. She immediately ran to her husband, and asked with fear in her voice.

„Are you okay? I didn't mean to! It was an accident.„ she said but Mikach smiled sadly and said.

„I see, it put a spell on you. These things happen... I was once chipped by Horde Prime ... And then I did certain things... He said and hugged her, and she felt tears running down her face.

„What's going on down there! I'm coming!„ Castaspella said from above and jumped down to them From above trying to lower herself with the same spell that Ireanis used, but the effect was not as good, and she hit the wooden floor quite hard…

„We just had a close encounter with... Something nasty. How did you know it was a monster if it was just a normal person? „ Mikach asked her, hugging her tightly. Then Ireanis snorted and said.

„Hello! This place has been abandoned for hundreds of years, and we come across a lonely person wandering around here. It's

obvious to any reasonable person that this must be a demon!„ the elven sorceress shook her head in disbelief.

She got lost in the darkness. She felt the shadows around her start to dance and shimmer, as if they were vapors or a liquid substance. The latter was probably the most accurate description, she turned on as she swam through the dark depths, as if she had fallen into a muddy lake. Only this time she had to swim towards the bottom, because she had abandoned the land of light long ago... She felt her consciousness slowly slipping away, as if she was falling asleep, but she knew she couldn't lose consciousness here because she would never wake Part of her mind told her that this would be the best option, and that it was the only way she could avoid the terrible fate that awaited her if she failed her dark master. Just fall asleep here, and spend eternity in a dreamless letagy. But she couldn't afford it, because there were a few people she had to take care of... She couldn't abandon them. So she kept walking, and it felt like she had been walking for centuries, her body was burning with the effort, and her feet felt as if they had been stripped of their flesh to the bone after an incredibly long journey. But she didn't stop, even if she had to crawl on all fours, she would get to where she wanted to go. But then a light flashed, and she suddenly found herself in a completely different place.

Bright moons shone in the sky, but the light was dim, as if they were half extinguished. The sky was blood red, a cold wind blew. She was on the top of the castle walls, in Brightmoon Castle, but it was rebuilt. The stone turned black, with scarlet lines that looked like veins in the blackened flesh.. She looked down and saw a city over which banners flew. At first, she thought that these were the banners of the Horde, that there was a completely different symbol on them, a black and red obelisk shooting sky, enveloped by lightning. She knew it was her banner, her symbol. The symbol of her own empire, in which she was the sole ruler. She saw all her enemies impaled on the field stretching beneath her, Mother, Hordak, and even Horde Prime … Others knelt in

shackles, looking at her fearfully , but also with admiration due to the victor On her sides stood They, her daughters. Adora stood at her right, radiating red light, clad in black armor, and held a sword of protection in her hand, although its blade was now black. At her left shoulder stood Catra, this time in the regulation uniform, with short-cropped hair, and a proud expression on her face. Between the impaled prisoners she saw endless ranks of soldiers in black and red armor, who chanted her name. "Shadow Weaver!" The supreme ruler… the queen of darkness. But as she looked around, she did not see one person… Her true daughter… Once she would have thrown entire Generations into the fire, She gave entire worlds to the Darkness for such power.. But now… Now she had changed. This was not what she wanted, she did not want to be the Dark Lord that Everyone would love, Or fear… This was not her destiny. She closed her eyes and the vision unfolded.

She had to admit that going down wasn't as easy for her as she tried to show it to Heart Gift . She didn't know why, but she wanted the AI not to see her as a crippled girl, Someone worse, someone crushed by the parasites and spores from Jadehell ... Which infected her body because her mother went mad because of her father and everything he did... When she thought about it, she became sad, and suddenly she slipped, and almost fell, although not very high, but Heart Gift caught her hand, and stopped her from falling. This was already the fourth chasm they had to go through. She wondered if this strange sorceress had foreseen this, she hoped not. Heart Gift, as soon as she helped her down, smiled at her and said.

„When you were in that underground place considering everything your body had been through I was surprised you were still alive, but you are able to match those with healthy bodies... It takes a lot of willpower, you know?„ she said, and at that moment she was very glad that her face was partially covered by the breathing device, because it was burning, she blushed so much.

„How are you girls? Is everything okay with you?„ Ireanis asked, and Heart Gift she replied before she could do anything.

„Tirin almost fell, but nothing happened to him, because he was very low, so there is a minimal chance that he will break his neck! „ she said, and She felt herself blush even more, and on top of that the sorceress replied.

„ That's good, because I'm bad at necromancy , and besides, I think the Captain would be unhappy if you became a zombie, so please take care of yourself!”

This was even more embarrassing. She lowered her head and walked toward the others.

Everyone was already waiting for her, even that big, gloomy clone that the captain disliked so much. She tried not to like him too, but it was hard because he hadn't done anything to make her angry... Was it possible to be ashamed of not hating someone?

„Well, we're pretty close now, so I hope nothing worse happens to us.„ Mikach said, looking at maps. She liked him because he was always so nice, even when he didn't know that she was his wife's navigator. She had to start thinking of him as someone who would be with her... her captain permanently. Did that mean that he would be a kind of... second captain someday, and Glimmer would become... well, someone quite close to her. Would she be able to live in a palace now? Actually, she had a palace somewhere, which she had never been to since she was a child. Would they let her live in Brightmoon? That would be weird, and maybe a little awkward... But she still wanted to become part of... her family... except there was one more problem. Reh-zar, the husband of the captain and her first mate. She liked him because he was nice to her, to her captain, but she knew they would never be as close as they could be with Mikach, because to him she would always be part Azlanti, and though he never showed her dislike, she could always see in his eyes that for him she was someone from the empire that had enslaved him. She guessed that discovering the truth would have serious consequences, but that wasn't her

problem, only the captain and her old family's. She saw that she was happy and worried at the same time, and she couldn't help her in any way.=. She could only hope that everything would work out somehow.

„Spit those words out! You'll be in trouble forever! Spit it out quickly!„ Ireanis shouted, and Heart Gift turned her head to the side, listening to the old man's dimensions.

„What? But what are you on about?„ said Castaspella, who was now a bit... her aunt? The Elven Sorceress looked at her as if she were someone who was exceptionally unintelligent, and replied.

„One of the first rules of dungeon crawling is to never say it's easy, and that we'll manage. Never! That means a terrible, agonizing death!”

Mikach and his sister exchanged a look, then Hordak said.

„It sounds absurd, how talking about victory can bring ruin to someone?!”

„That's quite logical and reasonable.„ Heart Gift said and everyone, even the strange furry creature looked at her. The android tilted her head as if she was surprised why no one understood you, and said.

„Oh, it's very simple, if everyone thinks that we're going to have an easy trip, they're not vigilant and it's easy to fall into a trap. It's quite obvious.”

„The golem girl is right! She is very wise, you have to listen to her! „ Ireanis exclaimed.”

She felt herself falling, falling into a bottomless abyss. She didn't scream, she didn't feel fear, only resignation. In fact, she liked this state. She was safe, nothing threatened her with pain of neither body nor soul. Many people would be terrified, but not her. She

was facing beings whose view could break the will of many people with a weaker psyche. She accepted that she was hated by most people she met. She had experienced unimaginable torment, and even her own death, so what could break her? And then a bright light surrounded her.

„Will you come to my wedding? I just wanted to make sure, because it's a pretty official event, and you have a certain position, so it would be good to know in advance. „ She heard Mikach's voice . She looked around, and for a moment and was sure where she was, only then she recognized her office in Mystacor. Everything was as she remembered, although she couldn't be completely sure, because so much time had passed... She looked at her hands, resting on the light blue counter. They were normal, without claws. She touched her face, and she didn't feel the Scars under her fingers, and her tongue didn't feel the sharp fangs. She began to breathe harder and looked up. She saw Mikach in front of her, smiling at her friendly, and she saw great joy in his eyes. He seemed younger than when she last saw him. He was about thirty, so he was about the same age when he was taken prisoner and then exiled to Beast Island... When she exiled him... He must have seen the shock on her face, because he frowned and asked with genuine concern in his voice.

„Is everything okay? I know it's a shock for you, especially since you were like a mother to me! Believe me, I can barely believe it myself, it's probably a huge shock for everyone.„ he said, and there was so much joy in his voice... She couldn't remember seeing anyone so happy in the past decades, even Rosie had never seemed so happy. She understood well what was happening now. She was being put to the test again. She was tempted again, but this time not with visions of power and authority… But something much worse. She was being allowed to forget everything she had done, to renounce all the evil she was responsible for... To become someone better, someone she always should have been, if only she had made different decisions... If she had made different life choices... In this world, No One would

suffer because of her actions. She wouldn't have been Cursed, and she would have been the monster that everyone feared. She wouldn't have killed all those people, and she wouldn't have turned anyone's life into a nightmare. She felt tears streaming down her face. Mikach looked at her a little scared and put his hand on her shoulder.

„Are you sure everything is okay?„ he looked her straight in the eye, and she responded trying to sound as if she was only touched.

„ It's just... It's such great news that I'm not sure how I should react. I'm just very touched, that's all...„ She said, then thought for a moment and asked. „I was just thinking about... About the Horde and all that it could do to our world. „ as she said this she was carefully observing the face of her former student. He nodded and said.

„Yes, I understand, that's why Angiee and I want to create an alliance that all the Princesses will join... Thanks to that, we will finally be able to win from her, you'll see. You are also invited as the Head Sorceress of Mystacor ... I'm sure we will win ha

He was right, without her Hordak would have no one to deal with the organization and management of his empire. And never will this last battle that broke the first rebellion take place , the future will be different. Of course, Horde Prime will continue his conquests, but sooner or later he will fall. Adora or Catra will never appear on Etheria, Nightgale will never be born either ... But it doesn't matter anyway, because it was all a lie. Somewhere out there the First Ones were still plotting their plans, her daughter was still Cursed, and the Lord Admiral was tightening his grasp around Catra's soul... She could escape into this illusion of a happy life, but not those she cared about... To whom she owed so much... Tears ran down her face again, and she unleashed the most powerful and destructive spell and threw it at her feet... Darkness enveloped her again...

He didn't make it to the last fight, which he regretted immensely... After all, something could have happened to the captain, and he wouldn't have been able to do anything to help her! It was terrible! Why did he promise himself now that he would stay as close to her as possible? Sometimes he would fall under her feet, But maybe that's better than her tripping over a mine or something like that... He wasn't sure if he could trust her companions... The android girl seemed the least suspicious. Tirin trusted her, and that was a pretty good recommendation, because the girl hadn't poisoned her, and she had a habit of doing so... according to what he had heard... He trusted the elf a little less, because she was a sorceress, but a decent one who cast spells that made a really big boom, and only such sorcerers were worth trusting. But the remaining Three... The clone was the eternal enemy of the captain, who only showed her boundless mercy and decided to spare him, probably only so that he would suffer even greater torment. Whenever he could, he looked down on him, to show him the superiority of the captain's loyal servants over such treacherous villains as he was! He knew that his captain would easily kill him at any moment, but on the other hand, she didn't have eyes in the back of her head, it would be worth thinking about it, so when she wasn't doing it, he watched him. However, the captain's new husband caused him more worries. He didn't like him in the slightest, and he suspected that he couldn't be trusted. He respected Reh-zar a lot and was worried about what he might say about his beloved having another partner... Besides, he was so old, and he was a wizard, but not as cool as Ireanis, he couldn't make explosions, nor did he set anything on fire. He understood that the captain had a child with him, but she saw no reason to stay with someone just because he had a child. He would have to talk to her seriously, otherwise it could end in tragedy! But the worst was his sister. There was something suspicious about her, she didn't look like she wanted to be in this place at all, she was an even worse wizard than her brother, and in general she gave the impression that she was a cannibal, or a dark cultist! He would have to keep an eye on her, although he was starting to run out of eyes! Finally, however, he had to talk to his mistress about something, because it was no longer giving him

peace. So when his lady captain stopped for a moment, he walked up to her and started tapping her leg with his paw.

„Lady! I think we need to talk because you know because when you know it will be you know.„ he explained, but Moonshadow looked at him for a moment, obviously not understanding what he meant, so he lowered his voice even more, he said.

„I'm talking about Reh-zar because you know he... Well, he's your husband, right? And this guy here is talking to your husband and I think that problems might come out of it.”

Moonshadow sighed heavily and spoke in a voice full of sadness and regret.

„My good and noble Tonado... I am aware of that. I... I have no idea what to do. I can fight the Azlanteans and the invaders, but I got myself into heart trouble like a teenage girl. Don't you think it's ridiculous?„ she said, and he saw tears in her eyes. He was about to hug her, but then they heard a voice behind them.

„Some people make worse mistakes... If you talk to them about all this, maybe you can work it out somehow... Some people make worse mistakes… If you talk to them about all this, maybe you can work it out somehow… My wife always says that honest conversation and hugs are the solution to problems…„ said Hodak and then they both turned to him and she lit a flare.

"How dare you eavesdrop on me!" She spat with anger in her eyes. But the clone raised his hands as if to show he meant no harm and spoke again.

„ I just have good hearing. That's how I was designed. I have to say that I followed you as I always follow those who stray from the rest here. It's a habit I developed when I had to watch over my wife. Entrapta has a wonderful mind, but unfortunately she is devoid of the instinct of self-preservation, and she must always be watched so that something terrible does not happen to her... When she sees some new technical marvels, she forgets about

the whole world.„ he said as if he was lost in thought, but it didn't change his mind, so he pulled out all six sabers and approached him

„I don't know, but for me, when you follow someone and you hear what you can talk about with your first officer, that's eavesdropping and that's it! Apologize to the captain.„ He said, but the captain signaled him to be quiet and said.

"You mentioned making mistakes. Was invading a peaceful nation one of them and are you comparing it to my heart troubles?"

And at that moment the clone seemed to hang down , but he said to you in a very sad voice.

„There is something even worse, and certainly more personal... I abandoned my own child... „ he said and then the queen looked at him with adoration, and was about to ask something when they heard Castaspella's scream."

„I found it! It's here! See, it wasn't that hard!"

She was trembling with excitement. She stood before a wooden gate, which perhaps resembled the maw of some terrible creature, but it was Here.!Just as Shadow Weaver had described it! I wonder how she knew it would be here. Had she wanted to go here in the old days? She couldn't be sure, and it probably didn't matter now. They were at their destination... She didn't really know what they should do next, the Dark Sorceress didn't say anything about it, and she didn't ask Ireanis about it either. The Saihe woman was now dancing with herself with joy, and she almost wanted to do it with her, but it would probably be interpreted differently than she should have. Her sister-in-law and that strange creature had gone somewhere to the side, but they immediately ran here together with Hordak. She refrained from wincing at the sight of him and pointed to the gate.

„We're here! We're here, behind that gate there'll be Stelarium ... You're almost there... All we have to do is get back... It might not be as easy as it seems, but we can see we'll get out of here!„ She said feeling a sense of relief, and then he asked.

„Do you know how to open it?”

Unfortunately, the question was not addressed to her, but to the silver-haired sorcerer, who only took a moment to realize that it was her they were asking.

„Oh wait, I'll take care of it in a moment. Hordak, come over here to me.”

She pointed to a smaller mouth, located on the gate itself, around which stretched twelve Horns. The former lord of the Horde grimaced, But what did he do as the woman asked him to do?

„Put your hand here, don't move it, and when you feel something, pull. I'm sure you won't lose a limb.„ she said pointing to the smaller open mouth, and the clone sighed heavily, but what did she ask him to do. Then she began to pull the horns of the creature for a long time, in whose mouth Hordak had his hand. The horns moved like levers, and she understood that Ireanis was entering some code. However, it took quite a long time, until finally her brother came to her and said.

„These horns represent the moons of our planet, and I guess we need to enter some specific date, let me think. „ he thought for a moment, then entered the code, and something clicked and the Gate began to open.

„t's a good thing those rumors about your hand being bitten off if the code is incorrect are untrue.„ Ireanis said, and Hordak said with a scowl .

“It tried, forty-eight times, and if you ask me, yes, I counted.” He pull outan armored arm, on which there were visible scratches. They were in place. And then suddenly Ireanis Curled up and let out a strange, piercing moan.

„ Is something wrong? „ she said as soon as she approached her, and the woman looked at Daria with eyes in which she saw pure horror, and said.

„She's here... The Annihilator has arrived.”

Chapter End Notes

And this is the next chapter, I invite you to comment and express your opinions.

Obedience

Chapter Notes

I'm sorry you had to wait so long for the next chapter and I invite you to comment.

She had to admit that she felt a strange pleasure from wearing this ring on her hand. She didn't know if it was the same with Calamity , but she could easily sense the power that lay dormant in it. It was like holding in your hand the key to a treasure chest full of unimaginable riches, or maybe it was more like she had a code that allowed her to simply decipher the language of an ancient Book that held the secrets to all the Mysteries of the Universe... She felt excited at the thought of what awaited her. Such great power was just within reach! She just had to... Oh, she just had to awaken an ancient artifact on an alien planet and hope that the lack of magic won't kill her by then... She wasn't really sure what would happen to her if the queen reconnected with her runestone, probably something much worse than just death. She laughed nervously, and Calamity gave her a suspicious look. She wasn't sure what to think of her ally. She was certainly beautiful and incredibly talented, but her eyes were always cold, she could see a hint of cruelty in her smile. Despite this, they were doomed to cooperate, so she had to accept her company somehow. That's how it is in life, you have to cooperate not only with those you want to. Despite everything, she missed the rebels, on whom she could undoubtedly always rely. Kyle went to get her out of those cursed dungeons, where she disappeared, even though she scared them all about what was there. Would Lady Cala do the same for her? Something like that probably yes, because it wasn't a big deal for her, unless she had to ruin her dress... But would she be able to risk anything for her? For anyone but herself? Anyone who knew Calamity's true side and knew that she wouldn't lift a finger for others unless she was following the orders of the Creeping Chaos. Her loyalty to Nyarlathotep

remained a separate question . The Great Outer God was powerful enough that could destroy even such a being as the spawn of Yog-Sothoth as easily, perhaps even more easily, than a man crushing a fly. But that was not true loyalty. Loyalty could not come from fear, for even the greatest fear eventually restrains. And besides, the Monstrous Aristocrat was not someone who was capable of true fear. The only thing that truly frightened her was her sister, and that spoke volumes about who this Evangeline might be . If she could sincerely pray to the benevolent gods, she would beg them to let this being bypass all who mattered to her.

She hadn't seen Aaravos for a long time. He hadn't said a word to her explaining why he had left her, but maybe that was a good thing. She still didn't miss his company. She knew that for someone like that she was just a tool. Maybe she was one for the Creeping Chaos, too, but at least they were the Great Outer God. For someone like that she really was just a speck, a spark that only existed for a time shorter than a blink. They had the right to treat mortals like tools, because what were they in comparison? But that sorcerer... He might have been incredibly powerful, but he was decidedly not a God. He was closer to someone like Lady Cala, and maybe that was why she was so fascinated by him. She asked if he was present, and when she heard that he wasn't, she seemed almost saddened, or maybe disappointed? She wondered if it wasn't infatuation, or even some form of love, if such a thing was possible for this monster with the face of a beautiful woman.

She was worried about her mother She was afraid of what would happen if Catra caught up with her. After what had happened in the castle, no one had any doubts that imprisoning the dark sorcerer was far too risky. Although she had only known her mother for a short time, she had already become an important part of her life, and she had no idea what she would do if she found out that she had been killed. Would she be more determined to seek the power with which to take revenge on those who had taken her from her? Probably, and if she succeeded, then everyone would finally understand, What true pain and torment is.

They had already reached the swamps, and she was quite rested, as was Lady Cala, although she suspected that creature never tired. Doctor Moors probably didn't know what exhaustion was either, but after all, he was a person who had locked his own brain in a metal can. Their companions, however, seemed both exhausted and frightened. This was not how they imagined serving someone they considered their God's chosen one. They were probably those cultists who did not fully realize who they served, what kind of beings the Great Old Ones and Outer Gods were. They were certainly not ready for what awaited them. Well, they were just meat for the machine, as it was sometimes said, and it was rather unlikely that they would see the end of this story, which was rather sad, because they seemed to be quite nice people after all. She could do nothing for them, though, she could see that she would be very lucky if she survived too.

One of the funniest things was that she didn't have to worry about mosquitoes. They were instinctively afraid to fly near her, as if she had a poisonous aura around her. Perhaps this was because she could kill any insects that came near her with just a wave of her hand. She laughed, because it reminded her of her recent Thoughts on the relationship between Calamity and the emissary of the outer gods. The aristocratic monster looked at her suspiciously , and asked.

„Don't tell me you inherited the same unstable and sentimental character as your mother.”

„Oh no my dear! It's just... We're in the swamps, and I wonder if mosquitoes or similar creatures bite you... „ she said, aware that it sounded even more absurd than Lady Cala could have expected. The aristocrat frowned, even more uncertain whether her interlocutor had really gone mad, and then pressed her lips together as if the question hurt her and said.

„They bite... My form is human enough to bypass most sensors, and it doesn't even regenerate certain things.. Mosquitoes die of course, but their bites still itch. Are you happy that you 've learned my weakness? Then please don't talk to me again!„ her

voice sounded more like she was embarrassed than angry. When she looked closer she saw that Calamity was very insecure. She understood that, until now this woman had more or less controlled her life, but now she had to go to a completely unknown place, where she might not have the support she was used to. Where no one would know the truth about her. And where she will probably have to curb her murderous impulses, and once again play the noble aristocratic lady, but this time she cannot fail by giving in to her uncontrolled desires, because she can no longer fail Nyarlathotep This time he wouldn't forgive her... If he ever did. After all, he had sent here the very creature she feared.

„Ah... I sense power, or at least its traces. My senses in this magnificent body are heightened in some ways, so I am able to see things that you miss. Look at the stones along this path, they were melted with some enormous amount of energy! Can you imagine the power it took to do something like that! And these plants, this is yet another case of introduction of alien species here, but from a completely different place! And take a closer look at these stones, they have something that resembles a nervous structure. It's fascinating! It's fascinating!„ said Doctor Moors , and Lady Cala smiled at him surprisingly warmly, and said with pride.

„This is a meager remnant, if you were on Carurystal... If you saw what was there, the entire infrastructure almost working, you would understand how great the Bloodstone Empire was. It's just a shame it was led by miserable machines, not by beings designed for rule„ she clearly radiated pride as she addressed the former Horde doctor.

„Well, I kind of regret that I haven't had time to see other worlds yet, but unlike mere mortals, I still have time for that. Do you think the inhabitants of your Planet won't be too suspicious of someone like me?„ replied the brain in the metal cylinder. Lady Cala laughed as if Dr. Moors had told a great joke.

„Oh! They are blind fools who will believe anything they are told, as long as it is done politely and appeals to their good hearts. I lived there for over twenty years and they did not even suspect who I was. Yes, a few people helped me hide my secret, but still no one even asked what happened to my family, everyone believed in accidents... Although I must admit that most of what happened to the Grayskull clan was not my doing, only other servants of the Great Outer God. Only my adoptive mother died because of me... In fact, it was she who gave me my name. „ at this point Calamity suddenly became strangely confused, almost sad. „You see, in order to take over the estate I had to poison her... The first dose didn't kill her, so I had to give her a second one, and unfortunately she figured it out. When she was dying we were in the room together, and then she looked at me, no one ever looked at me like that. Sometimes only Shadow Weaver… but not really. There was no hatred in her eyes, not even fear, just… Like regret. And then she said her last words. She said… "You are the calamity that has befallen our family, daughter… May you at least be happy." „ when she finished speaking, everyone was silent, although she suspected that for different reasons. Finally, however, she broke the silence.

„Are you happy?"

When she said this Calamity looked at her surprised and said.

"I am one of the most wonderful beings in the universe. Perfection incarnate. A living demigoddess. How could I not be happy?" she seemed to be trying to let absolute certainty ring through her hair…

„But that doesn't answer my question. „ She pressed further, and then the Monster Aristocrat narrowed her eyes at her and said.

„I see no reason to answer you such dumb question. We may be traveling together, but we are by no means friends, or anything like that, so I will not confide in you my feelings. Besides, someone like you would not be able to understand what is going on in that which is the soul of beings like you."

She didn't ask any further, because after all it was better not to irritate someone who could crush your head in their bare hands. But as she looked at the woman, whose long blonde hair fluttered in the wind, she saw something she had never seen before, and perhaps no one ever did. This being, who was after all truly a demigoddess, was also a kind of victim here. She might be a monster without a conscience, but could such a creature be expected to conform to the morality of mortals? She should never be like them. She had to live among beings who were alien to her, and whom she would never fully understand. She had been forced to wear a mask, and play someone she would never truly become. Surely, if she could be who she really was, she would be the bane of the Galaxy, but she could be honest in her wickedness. She understood it, because in many ways she wore masks too. So they were all unfortunate victims of the Will of Creeping Chaos on this expedition, and there was nothing they could do about it.

They passed the floodwaters rather quickly and reached the better preserved remains of a stone road created by… She wasn’t sure by whom, she didn’t know exactly who the Bloodstones were, except that they were powerful crystalline computers created by the ancient race of Krellans . She also understood that all of this was part of some great energy network that was supposed to stretch across the entire planet to draw Its power. It was similar to what the First Ones had done to this world, but she wasn’t going to judge a long-extinct species, whose work she had actually used to survive. They drove closer, she had to agree with Dr. Moors, that the local flora was strange. The plants grew too abundantly for such place, and on top of that she had the impression that they were growing in the beds themselves. She didn't know much about genetics and especially plant cultivation, but she was almost certain that programming something like this was incredibly difficult, especially since it worked after so many thousands of years. There were also fewer mosquitoes, and she wondered if they hadn't planted some insectivorous varieties of plants here, or maybe they simply didn't have natural food here. I didn't see any animals larger than a cat here that weren't reptiles or amphibians. This was probably also the result of the fact that

this place had been transformed in the old days by those who had created it… Or rather, the one who had created this place... She regretted a little that she hadn't had time to listen carefully to what her mother knew. Shadow Weaver is already in a similar swamp, as is Lady Cala, though they both went there for different purposes, but she's the one who'll hold the ring now, so she should be the most informed of them all. Of course, the fearsome aristocrat, despite her reluctance to share knowledge, and probably anything else, had passed on to her everything she knew, but she was not a scholar, and couldn't fully understand what she had seen. Well , she would have to try to investigate everything she experienced here herself. In a sense, this was also an adventure, even if not entirely planned. She smiled to herself.

Eventually, they reached the actual ruins. She thought she saw disappointment in Lady Cala's eyes, but Dr. Moors was clearly curious, and the other companions seemed decidedly frightened. In her opinion, these ruins were definitely... Ruined... Although not completely. She didn't know what to expect, she had never seen any ruins except, in a sense, a Fright Zone, but there was something here that wasn't quite right, but unfortunately she didn't have the experience to say what.

„We get off, we go to the center. There was always a Bloodstone there, and that's where we'll find what we're looking for.„ Calamity stated, not even ordered. But she had no reason to oppose her. Aristocrat had been in a similar place before, and from what she understood, all the Bloodstone bases were built in an identical way... It was practical, after all, this city was just part of one large device, it didn't need an individual character more than it was necessary to adapt to local geographical conditions or possibly the Strategic situation in case the vampiric gems were at war. Their entire group huddled together in a tight cluster, although the doctor was floating on his masks, holding on to the half-ruined Buildings... Half-ruined...

„This place wasn't completely abandoned. It has inhabitants, they care, although it's doubtful they know what they really were.„ She said looking at the overgrown road. She was right, here and there

she saw torn vines, in others she saw crushed grass. She could also see that roots that could threaten the structure were being removed, although not all of them, apparently those who cared for this place didn't fully understand how easily nature could destroy such a place if given enough time. Still, she had to admit that the inhabitants of this place were surprisingly good at hiding, and if it weren't for the fact that she had some knowledge of tracking drilled into her head she wouldn't have noticed anything. Lady Cala smiled to herself, and said.

„Finally, I found servants I can finally count on!„ There was joy in her voice, but the pair of cultists looked at each other in dismay. Well, they were expendable. However, Calamity shouldn't remind them of that, she was so carefree back then. I wonder when they realized that? Then the aristocrat looked at her and asked.

„Are you sure, so they are here? If so, I suggest you show everyone... the ring.„ she said looking at her, and straightened.

„You mean my ring, right?„ she looked straight into the beautiful blue eyes of the spawn of Yog-Sototh, smiling gently but meaningfully. Calamity returned her equally gentle and meaningful smile, and then replied in the tone of a polite, well-mannered Maiden.

„Yes of course, I meant your ring…”

She felt in her heart both a twist of triumph thanks to this and the Great victory and raised her hand up. She immediately noticed a commotion among the surrounding plants, and even smiled to herself.

„Come out! Nothing bad will happen to you! I swear!„ she said, fully aware that it was a lie.

She heard Whispers quiet, but very excited. She smiled sadly to herself, for she knew they took her for some sort of prophet, and she also guessed that they would rather disappoint Lady Cala.

After a while, small ones started to emerge from between the buildings and bushes. They resembled something between frogs, humans and lizards. They wore camouflage suits and held various kinds of yarns, stone blades and bows in their hands. Despite this, they didn't seem too threatening, unfortunately for them... Lady Cala watched them for a moment and then called out

„Does this planet have to be so fucked up? It's absurd. Instead of murderous, ruthless warriors I got... Frog dwarves?! What the fuck am I supposed to do with them? Attack walking machines? Dance and sing? It's absurd!” she shouted, and her Bone Blade on her forearm came out and she swung it violently, that the frog like creatures jumped back with a scream, but she sighed heavily inwardly, and stepped forward to cover the furious aristocrat.

„Calm, calm!„ she said in Aklo, hoping they would understand the language, although she didn't really count on it. It was hard to tell if they understood anything, or if they were simply placated by the tone in which she spoke to them. They began to whisper among themselves, and then Calamity frowned and said.

„It's a draconian ... But difficult to understand Dialect, but I can translate.„ the aristocrat seemed clearly surprised, and then she probably passed greetings to these creatures. They answered her after a moment, and then Lady Cala translated their speech.

"They claim to be called Cowl, and they have tended this place since time immemorial, at the behest of the great Warrior who liberated them. Was it one of the previous idiots? The one who rebelled against the First Ones."

She frowned, because she recognized the name. Cowls were fairy-tale little creatures that were supposed to help children. They were imagined in various ways, and children were often given stuffed animals to represent them. She didn't think they could be real beings. Apparently they were very few in number, on the verge of extinction, which they could easily cross if they did something careless, like irritate Calamity ...

"Tell them if it takes us to the center of this city," she said, though she doubted that the creatures help was of any use to them. Lady Cala again translated her words, and the creatures began to discuss among themselves in hushed tones, and then one who seemed to be the oldest of them began to speak in a sympathetic tone.

"She claims she would be happy to help the great wielder find the way to the heart..." Lady Cala smiled, clearly amused that her companion had become the object of worship by such beings.

They were led to a large dome made of the same veined stone. She had once thought of it as the heart of the city, but now she wondered if it might be better to call it the city's brain, for the dome resembled a skull all too much. Bloodstone was a computer, after all, a brain of sorts. She felt uneasy, thinking of what they were about to awaken. Theoretically, this thing was damaged, as if lobotomized , but how effective could it be against us? The Creeping Chaos would not hesitate to use even the most fearsome weapons to achieve their goals.

„The great shaman Sork will not take us any further, for this is a sacred place, and anyone who comes near will be punished.„ Lady Cala said, translating the words of these creatures, and then she smiled and moved towards the building, but the tall cultist called out.

„Lady! There could be traps like that!”

Calamity looked at him, smiled at the service and said.

„You're right, go ahead!„ She said, and then the servant looked around, but no one, including her, was going to stop him. So he sighed with resignation and would have moved towards the building. However, as soon as he got closer, something suddenly jumped out from between and bit into his leg. The man screamed loudly and grabbed his wounded limb, screaming at the top of his

lungs, and the aristocrat first looked in that direction with surprise, then jumped forward, drew her sword and plunged it into that place.

„That's very interesting! I've never seen them survive long enough to outlive their owner!„ he pointed at the creature she had pinned down . It looked like a large and fat version of the creature that nestled in her ear.

„So Another servant of yours, who obviously disappointed the hope placed in him, left this creature, and it made it here... You've already sent someone to retrieve this console, but apparently that didn't work either.„ Saihe said to the sorcerer, and he just smiled meaningfully. Lady Cala hadn't noticed him yet, she was just looking at the creature first, and then she looked at the servant, who was clutching the wound, and knelt down next to him. The girl with short horns also stood next to him, frightened.

"Will he be okay?" the aristocrat asked, and the man answered a question that was not addressed to him.

„I don't know if I'll be able to go on... „ he said, brought back from the pain, and Calamity looked at him gently. She guessed what the aristocrat was going to do, but fortunately for the poor cultist, something completely unexpected happened. Suddenly the creatures that accompanied them hid, and the sorcerer Saihe turned and looked at something behind their backs with concern, which made her feel a cold sweat break out on her back, because if even someone like that, who looks without fear into the eyes of one of the Avatars of Nyarlathotep felt concern, it meant that the situation was really serious. Everyone turned in the same direction as the sorcerer, although she was not sure about the doctor, who at that time was walking on the roofs, clearly not wanting to deal with the inhabitants of the city. Two figures were walking towards them. One of them was a woman with blue skin and eyes without pupils of the same color, but in a lighter shade. Her hair was green and blue, she wasn't sure what people she belonged to, but it certainly wasn't any living on Etheria. The fact that she wore the uniform of the Fearless Armada only confirmed that suspicion.

Metal balls floated around her, and her body was marked with disturbingly familiar scars. Next to her walked a tall woman in a mask made of overlapping metal plates that were supposed to imitate a face All of her limbs were cybernetic prosthetics, identical to those that Eti had... She had a red cloak on her back, and in her hand a very long sword with a narrow blade. Lady Cala, who had already noticed the sorcerer, looked in his direction, he told her not to do anything. When both figures approached, the woman with metal limbs took off her mask. And then Lady Cala's beautiful blue eyes widened with astonishment, disbelief, and agitation. Here, I will say, the whole being in front of them had a face very similar to the two feline girls she had already met, although her eyes were now made of metal, looking like the same metal from which her limbs were made.

„This must be some kind of fucked up joke!„ The Aristocrat shouted and reached for her sword, but then the feline woman moved so quickly that she didn't even notice, and she was already standing in front of them, the blade dripping blood. For a moment she didn't know Whose it was, and then she saw a bleeding wound appear on Calamity's neck. The Aristocrat made surprised eyes, and at that time she tried to move to intervene in some way, but long metal tendrils shot out of the other woman's body. One of them threw her in the cheek, and the others painfully tied her hands.

„Of course, the whole existence is a joke, didn't you know that? The child of one who sees through time and space should understand that by now.„ she said in a surprisingly grating voice. Lady Cala held her throat and tried to attack the cat girl, but she made several lightning-fast cuts, severing the tendons in the aristocrat's arms so that her arms fell to her sides.

„These wounds will eventually heal, as will the hands I'll cut off if you don't calm down, but the magic in this weapon will make it take a lot longer. So maybe you'll calm down and listen to what I have to say, because believe me, I'm not going to kill you.„ she explained and smiled, twisting her scarred face. „Ask your elven

friend who's pretending he's not there standing next to that sorceress.”

The sorcerer Saihe then spoke, and she repeated his words.

„Let her speak, I sense tremendous power in her... Almost comparable to She-Ra, at least when she doesn't reach her full power.”

Calamity threw an angry look at Aaravos but said nothing, perhaps because her throat was still full of blood.

„Back to the topic. This may seem strange to you, but it just so happens that we are probably on the same side... I know what you are, and I see who is standing next to each other. He is the chosen one of the creeping chaos, right? Well, I also have a patron ... He is Achaekek, the killer of gods... In a way, that connects us, although my power does not come from him, but from very ancient beings... But it seems to me that we all share a common goal... right? „ The woman said, and then Lady Cala regained her voice enough that she was able to laugh and get out.

„You want... To... Destroy...„ And she bared her teeth.

„ Among other things... Although this is not my only goal... But it does not concern you... I would like to know what your plan is...

„We must go to Xadia , where we will free the powerful sorcerer Aaravos , who will show us how to reach the world of the first...„ she said instead of the aristocrat, because she still had difficulty speaking...

„ It's a good start, but what next? Because discovering Eternia is just the beginning. Only then will the problems begin. Fortunately, i think your master has an idea…„ The cat girl said looking in her direction. Aaravos nodded...

„Yes, the sword that cuts through worlds... The Nova Sword... The bane of immortals... Created to kill, among others, those like me...

However, I was not supposed to be its target, but someone else... I think we all know who we are talking about... Unfortunately, or maybe fortunately, it never left my planet... Unfortunately, it was protected from us... It was used only once... „ And now, to her boundless amazement, she saw a great sadness on Aaravos face. However, he immediately looked in her direction and added... „I once told your mother about it, and that is why she was so fascinated by the Sword Of Protection... But now, apparently independently of each other, we decided not to tell you about this matter for now.”

It was intriguing, but she rather thought that there might be nothing major behind it, but her mother simply didn't want to give them too much information at once, since they had to complete all the tasks one by one anyway, and freeing the sorcerer was hard enough...

That sword… The weapon was made to kill She-Ra and that guy Kyle was turning into with his blade. And then she remembered the event in the underground… How the inquisitor had talked about Eti… And about Rosie… Rosie had also been the work of the First Ones… She had seen what she could do when she argued with that girl… She had also heard about her attacking Adora, and almost winning…

„Your prosthetics... Like Eti's hand, they are remnants of some knights Eternals... and all three of you have something... You probably inherited it from the Lord Admiral, right? That's why he cares about you so much, it's not about the legacy... It's about something more, and something sinister at that „ she said quickly, almost to herself, feeling involuntarily excited about making a great discovery. The feline tilted her head to the side and said.

„You're right, it's something very sinister, even Blasphemous and indescribable, But unfortunately we don't have the time or desire to go into details. I wonder how you know so much... „ she approached her and as if she was wondering about something, but she never found out what the feline intended, because then Doctor Moors jumped down from the roof .

„She learned all this from an ancient machine of the First Ones, Which she found in the undergrounds of a certain castle... He said many interesting things, and we saw even more... For example, that there is a Second person like Adora, his name is Kyle ... And besides, there is someone else, someone else created to kill She-Ra... A certain deaf girl... „ The brain in the black metal cylinder shouted, and then Calamity sent her an angry look, because the secret was revealed. The feline Warrior turned her head to the side, and now she seemed to be really worried, so she thought for a moment, then whitened her gaze with her companion and said.

„This really complicates everything... It would be worth solving this problem... But it may be difficult...”

„ It just so happens that I can make something much easier for you, and also make sure that each weapon will serve our purposes. I have a device to control other beings, I can give it to you.„ said Lady Cala, and then slowly took out the gift from the void wanderers, showed it to the warrior and added. „ Put it on her, and we will have our enemy's weapon just for ourselves! „ a cruel smile was visible on the aristocrat's face. In the meantime, she narrowed her eyes and said to herself. "I'm sorry Eti, I was trying to help you."

„I think I'll be able to find her. She must be emitting a very familiar aura… “ the feline looked at her companion, and then realized that the other woman had something very similar to Rosie.

“You will head towards Xadia. From now on, in this task you have the support of the full might of the Fearless Armada and its allies, because it so happens that I have become my father's right hand. However, remember that killing gods is my heritage, and you are a demigoddess, so it would be better for you, pretty, if I didn't think I could practice it on you, do you understand? „ and then with one cut she cut off Calamity's hands „So that you would learn obedience and humility. Especially humility...„ and she took out a certain device, then cut reality and left them here alone in a pool of gore, which had already turned purple.

Stellarium

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She held in her hands a terrified sorcerer who was breathing heavily and kept repeating that the Annihilator had returned. Although they should have entered the vault, they had to calm down Ireanis as soon as possible… She hoped it was just an unjustified panic attack, brought on by being underground for so long and the general atmosphere of the place.

„She was, and still is, addicted to alcohol, so if we give her a little, maybe she'll be able to calm down.„ Angela said carefully, and in her eyes she saw concern bordering on fear.

"I'd cut off a finger or two, that always helps!" the hairy creature shouted, and everyone, including his captain, looked at him in disbelief, so he shrugged all six shoulders and added. "It's just a suggestion."

„Alright, alright! I feel better now! I just need to rest for a while longer... „ She said, panting heavily, and then she helped her up and they looked at the inside of the vault. There were countless amounts of all kinds of valuable items, most of them decorated with jewels and made of precious metals. She could also see a few books, covered in leather, but not all of the items looked magical, or completely magical. What's more, a few of them seemed to be the obvious work of the First Ones. She knew that she had come here for one of their artifacts, but she still felt uneasy seeing how many still survived after that terrible civilization.

„I think it's best if we search this quickly. There's no telling whether what Ireanis is feeling could pose a threat to us, but we

shouldn't stay here too long. „ Mikach said, and everyone silently agreed with him. They went inside.

„What do you think we should be looking for? „ she asked her brother, and he said, "I'll think about it."

„This must be some artifact of the First Ones… You know what? It would be best if you tried to detect magic and pointed to an object that doesn't emit it.

She nodded and cast spell, then let out a strangled cry.

„This is too much!„ she said, covering her eyes, because I know as soon as she started looking for the magical aura. It took a long moment before she regained her sight. Judging by the loud curses and the objects being knocked over, her brother and Ireanis were also trying to use this spell. Suddenly, however, she stumbled and had to grab the nearest shelf, but then she knocked a few things off it and broke something. She also smelled the sharp smell of musk and cinnamon. It seemed to make the room warmer, and also a bit stuffier, as if they were in a room with a burning fireplace.

„Oh, welcome… It's been so long since I had any visitors… You can't even imagine…... „ she heard a deep voice, and at that moment the rainbow spots before her eyes began to dissipate, and a woman stood before her eyes. She had light hair falling down her back and alabaster white skin. She was naked and, as far as she could tell, extremely attractive. She had two wings on her back, and short horns emerged from her head. She also had a long tail, and red claws. Actually, she looked quite ordinary, apart from the unusual outfit, but she had the impression that something was wrong with her... She gave off a sort of sinister aura, and perhaps most importantly, she appeared in a vault locked away, abandoned for hundreds of years... The situation was identical to the recent meeting with Glabrezu. She looked around the rest, but everyone was staring at the woman with a dull look, smiling slightly . She didn't understand why they were behaving like that. She probably had to do something, right? She

had never been one to take the initiative in such situations, so she looked into everyone's faces with pleading eyes. The horned woman looked at her companions with a very unpleasant smile until her gaze landed on her, and then she frowned as if in irritation.

„ Well, yes, there will always be one of you Normally I would set your companions on you, but I have been deprived of amusement for so long that I will happily do it with my own hands….„ She said and walked towards her, straightening her fingers, in a way she often saw Catra do... She looked at the rest and then realized what this woman had done to them and with difficulty she refrained from bursting out laughing.

„Alright, have some fun.„ she said and threw a simple battle spell at the horned woman's heart, which she probably wasn't ready for... Small balls of energy hit her in the chest, but unfortunately she was never a master of War magic so the effect wasn't very impressive. Her opponent hissed loudly and then Wanted to jump at her to torn her apart, but then the little creature attacked her from behind with its sabers, cutting her legs, and the horned woman fell.

„No one will seduce my Captain!„ he shouted, and then Ireanis regained control over herself, an expression of rage appeared on her face, and she threw her own time, after which the woman let out a loud cry, and disappeared in a fume of sweet-smelling smoke.

„That was quite powerful Sucubi ... That she charmed you all so much... „ she looked in her direction, and raised an eyebrow. „ Almost all... Well... If some of you feel ashamed now, because of your weakness, then let's just assume that nothing happened.„ Said the sorceress, and no one protested.

Her destination was in a deep Valley full of twisted vegetation that was clearly tainted by magic. Powerful spells were used here, the

kind she had expected to experience in this place. It was exceptionally interesting and she had to admit that it filled her with hope as to whether her expedition made sense. Of course, it also implied potential dangers, but Millenia had already gotten rid of such mundane feelings as fear, at least the fear of death. She was curious about what had happened in this place. Maybe if she found a moment, she would question the local spirits, and there were quite a few of them left, about what had happened here in the past. For now, however, she had to content herself with the company of her newly-acquired undead. Unfortunately, a large part of them had fallen behind. Only a few shadows and wraiths kept up with her, as well as one servant, whom she had special respect for. The Nightwing flew right behind her, dragging a Shadowy trail behind it. It would be very useful in the near future, Regardless of whether Calamity and Despara were lying… It would simply help her kill other people. But deep in her dead heart she felt that all of this was the sincerest truth…

Umbracor resembled a huge tree, or maybe rather just a tangle of roots, it had to be admitted that it was quite an original, and quite visually appealing idea, and perhaps she would have thought of such a shelter herself, if it weren't for the fact that she was in a red dragon, and her fire was still burning... She would have to be very careful in this place, so as not to burn it down... too early. After all, she didn't want all the treasures hidden here to be annihilated...

She landed on a wooden dome, still flapping her wings slightly, and tore the wooden structure apart, which in her case was like breaking twigs. Her servants landed behind her, waiting for orders. Then she changed form, and stood over the huge structure, so as a human, she could enter inside. Pressing herself in her natural form would be very uncomfortable. Besides, over all these centuries, she spent more time as a human, so she basically got used to this form. However, when she delved into the Dark corridors, she felt Something absolutely unusual. Power, with a hue that she knew very well. However, they had no right to appear in this place. All the graduates of Magambya University had been dead for thousands of years, and most likely died along

with Golarion ... However, she remembered something, a certain absurd rumor about the person she once fought. Could it be that by some unimaginable twist of fate she ended up here? She smiled to herself at the thought of meeting someone from her old life. This trip might turn out to be more interesting than she ever expected.

After... the unfortunate encounter with this naked and absolutely gorgeous woman nothing happened, which was good, the problem was that nothing happened , because they found no trace of this Stelarium ... Of course, there were so many treasures in this place that it could take hours to find what they were looking for. Unfortunately, they probably didn't have that much time, so they had to really hurry... Theoretically... Ireanis didn't sense her old enemy again, so maybe she was just imagining things... She was definitely traumatized a woman who had to go through a lot. Such experiences change people, and usually they are not pleasant changes... He knew that all too well... To this day I can't sleep in bed... And he felt best in his hut in the mountains... He had heard that the Saihe woman had escaped into alcohol to forget the traumas she had experienced. He wished very much that she had imagined return of her enemy, but as he looked at his companions, he was less and less convinced that he even felt a little ashamed, disbelieving the sorcerer. His wife, in particular, seemed to take her words seriously. When they stood next to each other to search the same shelf by chance, he asked her.

Do you know anything about what Ireanis is talking about ?

Angela hesitated for a moment before answering him.

"I hear that Lord Admiral Antares is served by a great red dragon, and when we left Brightmoon , I saw a similar creature on sensors..." She said quietly, and he sighed heavily and said.

„That doesn't sound good. I'd like to believe that all this is just a coincidence, and this creature just flies nearby, But let's be honest, you can't count on such a coincidence...”

His wife didn't answer, but he saw in her eyes that she smiled and gently touched his face. It warmed his heart for a moment and for a moment they just stared into each other's eyes until he heard Hordak's hoarse grunt behind him .

"I don't want to interrupt your...looking at each other, but I think I found what we were looking for." The former ruler of the Horde said, and all of them turned to him, slightly embarrassed, like teenagers caught making out.

„Well, show me. Let's see if this thing will show us the way to this Xadia... „ He said and approached the clone. He took a small ball made of blue crystal from the box and held it up. It seemed that stars, maybe even entire Galaxies were spinning inside. Despite this, he wasn't entirely sure if they had found what they were looking for.

"How do you know that's what we're after?" he said, and Hordak smiled crookedly and said.

„Just put it to your eye and you'll see.”

He hesitated, because he didn't know How much he can trust the Klon that this wasn't a trap, but then he shrugged and did as I asked him.

And then the whole universe opened up to him. He saw hundreds of thousands of suns, many galaxies... whole clusters... He tried to make sense of what he was seeing, but wherever he looked, waves of information flooded him. Data flowed straight into his brain, and there was no way he could repel it. It was downright painful, especially since he completely did not understand what he was seeing. He had no knowledge of celestial physics, astronomy, or many other sciences, and now he was asked to memorize data that was incomprehensible to him. He tried to control it all, but

the more he pushed away what he was seeing, the more he got lost in this flood of knowledge... Finally, he panicked and started looking in all directions, but it only made things worse, and he felt sick in his stomach. After a moment, someone grabbed him tightly and the images disappeared. He saw Hordak in front of him, who was looking at him with some surprise, holding Stelarium in one hand and supporting his arm in the other.

„You overreacted more than I did... Probably because you're not technically savvy... I know a lot about these things, but I still felt... overwhelmed... „ the clone said, and then he felt a rush of nausea, so Hordak moved away from him, and let him throw up his travel rations.

„Maybe it would be good, If my wife saw this, you would probably understand more of it. Or her brain would explode... „ said the former ruler of the Horde.

"So what do I have to do with this?" his sister asked, and then Tirin walked up to them with the Heart Gift ...

„ e can help. I'm really good at navigation and astronomy, and Heart is... Well, they did her.. The First Ones… very literally.„ she seemed to look apologetically at the ancient AI, but she just smiled at her and said.

„Nothing happened! You're right, my mothers either belonged to the First One race, or was created by them.”

The Azlanti woman seemed to smile at her new friend, but then they heard a deep female voice through the door.

„The girls are right, let them check it out, I'm not preventing you from accessing this knowledge, because it may turn out that I will need more allies to the place I'm going. However, when you're done, I advise you to give me this artifact willingly, because otherwise you will join my new wonderful army.

When he turned around he saw a naked woman high up with Flame red hair and brown-red eyes who was smiling widely,

showing black fangs, shadows swirling behind her… He knew who she was, he had seen her at his daughter wedding, but only from a distance, and dressed, and he had never exchanged a word.

„Ashaq ... Die, you bitch!„ Ireanis screamed and threw a spell at Lady Sorrowflame that looked like some kind of ice projectile

He saw how the Woman with red hair with one movement of her hand dispel spell thrown by the sorceress Saihe , and then smiling she casts her own spell, a green beam that hit her in the chest, making her fall to her knees as if without strength. He growled and tried to hit the newly arrived, but she grabbed his armored hand and effortlessly pressed him against the wall, as if he were again the weak Clone he once was. It was something terrible, but the woman only smiled at him and threw him as if he were a puppet. He landed practically painlessly, and immediately jumped to his feet, but the former queen signaled him to hold back.

„I advise against harming my companion. I know that you have done her much wrong in the past , and you should not be surprised that she is angry with you. „ Angela said, but then the red”haired woman laughed in a deep voice.

„Hurt her? But I saved her, thanks to me she is alive... Unlike her companions, whom she sacrificed. „ she said, indulgently, and he looked at the helpless sorcerer, who was staring ahead with a dull gaze... Everyone seemed confused, but then the newcomer added. „However, it was not Ireanis that I wanted to talk about. As I said, we have the same enemies and I see no reason to interfere with obtaining this information. I have lived for a Millennia’s and I will live even longer, so I see no reason not to wait a little longer. In the future, perhaps we will resolve our... dispute with Miss Ireais. However, now is not the time for that, at least for you.„ she said and continued smiling.

„I don't believe you're doing this out of the goodness of your heart... I know quite a bit about dragons, and dragons like you are rarely kind.„ Said Angela, who was leading the conversation, probably because she knew the most about these creatures out of all of them, except perhaps the silver-haired sorcerer, who was not in the mood to talk right now. The redhead raised an eyebrow and said.

„I see that your stay in the Star Empire has developed a healthy suspicion in you. You are right, in fact I simply wish that any traps left by both the sorcerers here and the members of that ancient race would be activated by you. That is a fair offer, isn't it?”

The former queen looked at her navigator, who nodded bravely and the Pirate agreed. Both girls began to examine the device, and after a moment they froze practically motionless. Ashaq looked at the artificial intelligence in the girl's body, with interest, but also a bit of suspicion. She certainly had no idea that Heart Gift and Tirin were members of this expedition. She probably also didin’t know who their newest companion really was... He wasn't sure if it would be good for her to find out.

Suddenly Tirin let out a shriek, and fell to the ground, and her friend caught her and said:

„We managed to get the information, but Tirin seems to have had a sensory overload, but don't worry, she'll be fine!„ she seemed scared and kind of sad...

A nd then a black light emerged from the artifact… For a moment it enveloped the entire room, and another figure stood between them It was difficult to determine what gender it was, because it had no facial feature and it face was smooth as we make from porcelain, and it was dressed in black wardrobes that looked as if they were made of smoke. She looked around and said

„You freed me... and in return I will... I will devour you... This is what my gratitude looks like, you fools...” And suddenly he noticed that all of his companions, even the terrible woman who had just

arrived, were curled up on the ground. They hid their faces in their hands, groaning and mumbling. Without waiting for what he would do next, he raised his weapon, and aimed it at the monster, but then she looked in his direction, even though she had no eyes.

He was alone... in the wasteland. I remember that moment in his life. It was right after he arrived in Theria with his ship and was looking for... anything... But now he wasn't the same lost clone. He had his knowledge, he had his past... The past he always wanted to escape from... And now that no one remembered him... Everyone had forgotten about him, and his deeds. They had forgotten about his crimes, about the war he had fought for decades. Part of his soul wanted it to stay that way, for him to disappear from the whole world. He felt a strange anxiety, not coming from him, but from someone else, but he didn't care. He closed his eyes and let the relief spread through his body and soul.

„No! It's not like that! You can't be happy because no one remembers you! Stop doing that! Stop it!„ monster said and then he came back to the real world and he remembered exactly where he was and what they were supposed to do. So he smiled crookedly and aimed the Blaster towards the creature's face and fired. The beam pierced the creature through and through and it fell but did not die, but then the red-haired woman looked in her direction and the creature burst into flames, which immediately went out.

„So it was worth it for you to be the first to examine this artifact. For the first time in millennia, someone has managed to strike fear into my heart... You could say I feel gratitude towards you, you copy of blasphemer.„ she said, baring her black teeth.

„You're welcome...„ he said, smiling grimly.

Immediately afterwards, the former queen stood up and approached her protégé, who was supported by Heart Gift . Meanwhile, Mikach and Castaspella supported Ireanis. Seeing that

Angela was having trouble lifting the girl in the biomechanical suit, he approached her and wanted to lift her, but then the former queen growled at him.

„Hands off her…”

He took a step back, but no more, and said.

"I'm the strongest of you all, even without armor, and it would make the most sense for me to carry her."

The Queen looked at him with hostility.

„I don't trust you, you treacherous bastard...”

Her words almost didn't hurt him... Almost. He sighed heavily and began to explain, trying to keep the irritation out of his voice.

„Many bad things can be said about me, but I don't think I've ever betrayed anyone... At most Horde Prime ... But I don't think anyone regrets that ... Since the beginning of this expedition, I've never once given you a reason to accuse me of anything...”

Angela wanted to say something, but Ashaq interrupted her.

"Please... If I wanted to watch people arguing aimlessly, I'd watch Elven soap operas..." Her voice was cold and there was a warning note in it. He wasn't sure if fighting her would make sense when everyone was healthy, but now that they had to deal with two members of their expedition, they didn't stand much of a chance.

„Allow him to do it, my love…„ Mikach interrupted unexpectedly. „I have reasons to hate him as much as you do, but he deserves a little trust.„ He looked at his wife significantly, And she sighed and said.

„Agreed, but it's not because I trust him, but because I trust you.„ she gave him a sharp look, but she let Tirin be taken on her shoulders. She was indeed heavy, but only compared to his wife and other people without this suit. Lifting her was no effort for

him. However, he felt that while lifting the girl he also felt that a huge weight was falling on his bank...

The dark sorceress's friends left the room rather hastily, leaving her alone with the ancient artifact. Actually, they seemed quite interesting people, but she had no time, despite what she said, to make new friends... As they left the Vault, she turned to the young queen's father.

"I advise you not to leave your kingdom for too long, because from what I know my employer has some things planned…" she explained and the former king looked at her questioningly, but said nothing more. At that time, it was the fault of this group for helping to recover the artifact. When they left, she picked up the metal ball and looked into its center.

During her incredibly long life, she had acquired many skills, including knowledge of Astronavigation, as well as computer science and many other things, which were very useful to her now. When she looked into the device, a view of the entire part of the universe known to the First Ones unfolded before her. She quickly learned the location of the planet they were looking for, but that was not what interested her, at least not only that. She looked into the archive and ordered them to find the planet there, which should be in the location where Golarion used to be. Some things were of course secret from her, such as the location of the First Ones' headquarters, but they did not hide where her home was... Or what happened to it. Now she could learn the truth. She had not given the exact date of Golarion's disappearance only an estimate, so it took a while to find the exact moment. And then she saw... The planet was not simply destroyed, but erased from reality, annihilated in a way that could not be described, only the Absalom station survived. But what she was looking for was the place where the energy discharge that led to this destruction came from. She ordered the source to be shown, and then Etheria was indicated, and the cause was given as a test shot from a

weapon called the heart of Etheria... It was performed by Major General Mara Espadone...

She stared ahead for a long time, maybe even hours. She felt nothing and thought nothing... She had never felt truly dead, until that moment... And then a flame ignited in her heart... The black flame of destruction... She guessed that igniting it was the reason Shadow Weaver had convinced her to come here, but she didn't care, and was even grateful... But now all she could think about was bringing death to Eternia... Or rather, Un-Death...

Chapter End Notes

> Here is the next Chapter, I invite you to comment and express your opinions.

Tower of Yithil

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Rechiza looked uncertainly at Arkan”tar, who seemed to feel at ease in the company of crowned heads. She was not used to such environment. Yes, she was friends with the Lictor of the Order of the Eclipse, but a hellknight was something completely different, Janos di Vir was a man of a very honest disposition, and in fact, not at all as severe as one might expect, at least if one did not make deals with dark forces, and she was far from such practices. Now, however, she was in front of the local ruler, and she felt uneasy, even if nothing threatened them here... Probably. The locals were perhaps famous for their kindness , and the previous actions of Prince Zed and the doctor's daughter made the locals friendly towards them... However, she was still afraid of what might happen. If they refused to support them, they would be grounded on this planet at best, but if the Archduke decided that he didn't like that answer, then Etheria might end up with one less Princess, because she had no doubts about who would emerge victorious from this fight. But she was probably worried in advance, or so she told herself.

They were in a throne room, not as large as one would expect a princess to be, although then again, it wasn't a large kingdom, at least not by galactic standards. The locals respected their queen greatly, and not just in the way a good king was usually liked. Most of the local princesses were held in high regard, but Sweetbee was respected almost like a minor deity... But when she stood before her, she understood that there were reasons to perceive her that way. She was a witchwarper , a magic uuser who inspired the least trust of all. She twisted reality with the force of her will, often tearing it apart, in a brutal and unsettling way. This woman... She sensed that she wielded psionic power,

very powerful, capable of crushing the very soul of someone with a weaker mind. As soon as she spoke to their minds, only she, and of course the archduke and the false automaton, didn't jump in fear.

„You are looking for a way off this planet... A way to a place where something very precious to you was left... „ It wasn't even a voice, but as if a second mind was thinking in her head

"I'd say something that could be valuable to all of us. There are already important things happening in the universe..." Kane said, and then everyone heard laughter.

„There are always important things happening in the universe. We may have been separated from the rest of the Galaxy for thousands of years, but that doesn't mean we're that ignorant, or at least I'm not „ that laughter made her feel a little pain. This was going to be a very long and unpleasant conversation.

„But this time, these important things concern you and your future... Your world still has significance for the Entire universe...„ Kane said in a voice worthy of a Royal herald. However, Sweetbee Laughed again in their minds.

"Again? Do you know how many times in recent years the lives of my subjects have been threatened because someone felt they needed Etheria and the secrets it held to further their plans?" This time her voice was almost painful, making her wince. The Archduke didn't show it, so it would have made a stronger impression on him.

„And so it will be in the future, some places are cursed with the fact that they attract the attention of everyone around. You just have to start getting used to it, or rather prepare for such an inevitability...„ Kane said in a still calm voice, as if he was only conveying greetings from a friendly monarch.

" And how will your help make my subjects safer?” She asked again, seeming even more amused than before. That's when she

decided to speak up.

„My name is Rechiza Charcal. I am a sorceress of sorts, but I was also an archaeologist and researcher of ancient civilizations. The remains of one of them did this to me.„ She raised her hood to to show everyone how badly she had been maimed during one of her expeditions. Everyone could see her metal eyes and forehead devoid of antennae. Everyone sucked in a hiss of air, except for the princess, of course, which spoke well of her. After all, the ruler did not get carried away easily by emotions. Despite everything, she seemed to be interested in her person. She looked at the Archduke, and he seemed completely calm, only smiling slightly, as if he expected everything. Considering, What she had learned about him, it was very likely.

"To show you many of my subjects who were similarly maimed by Horde Prime and his clones, for as you know, his hatred of my people was great," she said, this time without even a hint of bitter mirth.

„However, if you don't help us, many more people in your kingdom will suffer, maybe everyone will die... „ The Archduke said seriously, but if the Princess had eyes like humans, she would probably roll them now when she heard his words.

„Do you think I haven't heard this in the old days? Once I supported the Rebellion and many of my subjects lost their lives. Later, thanks to members of the same Rebellion, Horde Prime came. But at least they weren't strangers... But you come here and say that only you can save me... Me and my subjects. Tell me, my dears, why should I trust you?„ said Sweet Bee In their minds. This time they felt sadness from her, combined with some fatalism...

„Because it doesn't cost you anything... „ Arkan-tar said as if explaining why his goods were the best in the entire marketplace. This time the princess seemed a little more interested.

„What do you mean, it costs nothing? There's always a price, isn't there? Only fools would tell me that they would risk themselves for strangers for no reason... Especially ones like you. I am powerful... I can feel your thoughts... At least the superficial ones... I know that you and that rat person are greedy for power and wealth. The doctor has a desire for revenge in his heart, in his heart that doesn't beat, just like his daughter. Prince Zed is afraid... And the archduke... His mind stands before me closed as if behind a diamond barrier, and that makes him the most suspicious.„ She explained and for a moment everyone was silent, and she was sure that the entire court was looking at Kane with concern, probably no one had resisted the power of their ruler's mind before.

„What about me, and my companion? „ Dilayla asked unexpectedly. „ Don't you think our motives are somehow... suspicious?”

Princess Sweetbee looked at the mercenary with curiosity and said.

„I sense a sense of guilt in your mind... But also a sense of mission, a desire to do good and serve a cause greater than yourself...”

„About guilt... I brought here the resurrected Shadow Weaver and a certain spawn of one of the Outer Gods as well as Catra's father , who is in fact a former dictator and war criminal, so I guess I have reason to feel guilty.„ Said mercenary , and when all the courtiers, though not the princess, looked at her in disbelief, she added. “So no one told you anything? I'm sorry, but it's better that you know everything...”

For a moment, everyone was shocked , and Dilayla's companions , including herself, were furious, but both the princess and Kane seemed pleased. So they probably saw it coming too... At that moment, she decided that it was her turn , so she sighed deeply and said.

„As for me, I feel fear, I won't hide it... And also Anger for what they did to me... So, yes... You're right, maybe I have base motives... But I am also a warlock hunter. I fight those who use dark powers. I oppose the servants of darkness that exist between the stars! Maybe I am not a hero... He didn't prevent the Lord Admiral from arriving and I didn't see through Shadow Weaver or Lady Cali, for that I will never forgive myself... However, what we are fighting is more powerful than you can imagine, but more importantly, it is driven by very simple motives. They simply want to cleanse the galaxy, to have a place for themselves to grow. To be alone in the universe, never to have to share their living space with others, to interact with other cultures, to learn their customs and lifestyles... They not only want to be the First, they want to be the Last. They have allies, many weapons, terrible weapons... Including The Hunger That Cannot Be Satiated... I know you have reasons to trust me, but Take a chance... I promise you that we will not threaten your kingdom.„ She knelt down on one knee and said.

„Please, let us help you... Let us save the universe...„ silence fell after her words, heavy and oppressive. And then the princess said in their minds slowly and thoughtfully, worthy of a ruler.

„I will not allow you to go to the swamps of Krannor Rill... A great evil lurks there. Although it was destroyed many centuries ago, it has not been completely defeated... „ And then I looked at the Archduke of Carurystal and said

„I remember you Kane Adamson... I have the memory of all my predecessors, and one of them knew you... Very well... We know who you really are, and that you once awakened one of the bloodstones and how it ended from the world... However, where you want to go you can get by another way, which you also know well. You will enter the path of Yithil, you will enter his lair. You have already managed once, now it should be easier for you... Recently another person entered a similar path, she was not as experienced as you... Although I cannot vouch for your companions… But that's a sacrifice you're willing to make... Right?

„ she looked at him with her insect eyes, and the man with a look as terrible as the matter of death smiled and said.

„It's exactly as you say. Thank you for your help... You are extremely... gracious...„ there was a barely perceptible note of concern in his voice… and that in itself made her heart skip a beat…

They were led into the jungle the next day. Dilayla had to admit that it was surprisingly pleasant here. It was never too hot or too cold in her armor anyway, but here it was pleasant enough that she could walk around without a helmet. It lacked the usual stuffiness of such places, and it didn't seem to be so crowded with decaying vegetation... It was also full of animals, both birds and colorful insects. Most of them seemed to be local, as were the plants with blue-green leaves. As she approached a large butterfly with four eyes that looked like they were carved from crystal, Rechiza stood next to her and said.

"This place hasn't been terraformed as much as other places on the planet. In fact, the locals are a much more homogenous population, at least for this place..."

„Do you like it here? Because it looks a bit like this place around your home?„ he unexpectedly asked the Lashunti woman ... Who looked at her with surprise, visible even in those metal eyes, then smiled sadly and said.

„A bit like that. It's similar here to Castroval, but not entirely. Only that... the locals are Lashunti ... After I was maimed, after I lost my psionic abilities. I always feel like something worse in the company of representatives of my species. It's hard for you to imagine that...„ There was a lot of bitterness in the voice of the sorcerer hunter.

„Well, I suffered too, but my prosthetics are a perfect substitute for the real limbs... In your case, nothing is that easy, is it? „ she

looked at Lashunti and she smiled sadly.

„And then there are those eyes... I can see things that others cannot see. Usually i could see the inscriptions in the language of the First Ones... And above all understand Him... A wonderful gift from Doctor Sidonius ... „ She looked at the metal, airtight coffin built by the Doctor's Two servants, where the ancient vampire was staying, „ But he still suspected that it was hiding something more... But I will never learn that from him... „ She saw how the Witchwarper pursed her lips in a mixture of anger and helplessness... She patted her correctively and smiled as friendly as she could.

„Don't worry, You have me with you now. I can be your friend... If you want me to. Of course, don't imagine anything more! I'm already taken!„ She laughed and seeing Rechiza's gloomy look , she added. „You too!”

Rechiza might have passed herself off as a monster and cultist hunter, but when it came to matters of the heart, she acted like a teenager.

„I have absolutely no idea what you're on about.„ The Witchwarper said it so quickly that Dilayla couldn't help but giggle at it.

„Everyone here can see that you have a crush on Arkan-tar, which doesn't surprise me, because someone with your preferences has a choice between... A lizard, an annoying vampire, a guy with eyes as scary as death itself, an automaton, and this scholar. The choice is pretty obvious, and it seems that you were drawn to each other from the beginning ... To be honest, you fit together perfectly... And you complement each other... „ she explained with absolute sincerity. She didn't know anything about relationships, she was a bloody mercenary who had only had fleeting affairs in her life... at least until recently... But she did know a thing or two, and in the case of these two, it was all too obvious.

„If you say so... But Arkan-tar... „ she said, but then Dilayla rolled her eyes and said.

„He feels the same way about you, maybe a little differently, but similar enough. Maybe he's reached an age where he wants to settle down, especially since we've all grown up and become a little wiser during this trip...„ She said and smiled at Rechiza again ... The Witchwarper smiled too, and looked ahead with a considering gaze for a moment.

„I wasn't looking at it that way... Thank you for your wisdom... „ she finally said . The Mercenary smiled at her and said.

„It's the first time in my life that I hear someone say that I'm speaking wisdom. but if it happened to me once, let it happen to me a second time... Kiss each other before this is all over, or at least before we go down that damn road."

„I'll think about it... Thank you again for your words... „ said Lashunti and they set off into the jungle.

They hadn't been walking for as long as he had expected. Actually, this tower was relatively close to the city. When they reached it, the moons were just setting, they still had a few minutes of light. Of course, it didn't matter that much to them... They didn't intend to conduct an Excavation here... From what he understood, this place had been very well Explored. Besides, it was obvious as soon as they got here. The hill on which the tower was located had been cleared of smaller bushes, only the largest trees were allowed to grow here, which hid the ancient structure from the eyes of those who could fly over it... Although with modern equipment they probably wouldn't have any problems finding this place. Even the guards that had been left here probably didn't matter much if someone wanted to take an interest in this tower... It seemed, however, that there was something about this place that scared strangers... He himself felt fear, true, but constant and starting as soon as they approached.

However, he was used to investigating ruins and places of this type... I wonder if ordinary people simply did not give up on looking into this place, simply convincing themselves that there was nothing interesting here... People could be extremely convincing when they wanted to deceive themselves.

The tower, however, was a disturbing sight. It was made of white stone, maybe not entirely white, more the color of bone... Its structure seemed strange, he examined it as soon as they approached, it seemed to be covered with a glassy, extremely hard substance, but he had the impression that the interior was disturbingly spongy, giving a strangely organic impression, and his experience told him that it did not bode well. The building was quite tall, did not overwhelm with its garden, quite narrow and it seemed that its Top was uneven as if it consisted of many protruding spikes... In its entirety, the building resembled one large tooth. It was definitely disturbing... He should get used to this feeling, right?

The entrance resembled an irregular hole, without a door. Virtually anyone could enter there... If only he managed to overcome the anxiety he felt when approaching this place. Several guards in the colorful armors of the Royal Guard were guarding this building, but even they were not approaching the interior. The interior was covered with a blue-green substance that resembled meat that had crystallized in its structure. There were no decorations or anything of the sort here. At first glance, it seemed that this tower had no purpose... Inside, in a recess, there was a gate covered with a membranous membrane on one of the walls, which gave the impression that it led to the insides of some gigantic creature... The Archduke grimaced at this sight and said.

„ What we're going to do now is dangerous... This tower is a fragment of an ancient being known as Yithil ... Along with Sataka ... And a few other creatures whose names I don't know... These are Void Hunters feeding on... The souls of other beings... Because you see, this gate is the entrance to the digestive system of this creature... „ he looked at them all, and most of his companions were turning green, except for the lizard and Dr.

Quin, because in their case it was impossible. „This way we will be able to get to another world, in this case Xadia ... I only hope that we will manage to get there relatively quickly... As we walk this path, you must remember one thing... Do not stop, just keep moving forward... I am in no danger... I have already been inside him, and it did not end well for him... But it was not easy... Don't stop under any circumstances, no matter what you see. " Kane's voice was very calm, too calm for what they were supposed to do... Then he focused and said a few words in the Aklo language, in which he asked the being of whom this building was a fragment, to open a passage for them. When he fell silent the entire building trembled and then the aristocrat with the eyes of a murderer entered the membrane... Everyone hesitated, including him, but then Rechiza approached him... She smiled and, hugging him tightly, kissed him on the lips... And then she let go and ran behind the membrane...

Rechiza walked forward… She knew where she was, in a wasteland cursed by devils and demons, where she had found that ruin… She felt, for the first time in years, the echoes of the Thoughts of other beings, which meant that she had regained her antennae, and the colors were already normal, as if she had her real eyes… Of course she had them, why should it be any different? She saw that she should stop and run… Ahead of her was a doom… A rock incinerator had been installed … A weapon that could kill her… That could maim her. However, she remembered that she must not stop… Or else… Or else something bad would happen… She had to walk forward… Suddenly she saw a flash brighter than a thousand suns and felt a wave of heat that made blisters appear on her skin from burns, but she still did not stop… She lost her vision again, and her antennae, probably with her face, were fried, much more than the first time. The pain she felt was impossible to describe, but she knew… She knew she would stop… She would be lost, so she walked foward… And then suddenly the light flashed again, and she was surrounded by the light of the sun… She saw the entrance outside… She wanted to go in there… But.. She looked back… What she saw made her stop in place, taken by such terror that she was unable to

describe it in words… But then she felt someone tug on her by the lapels of her cloak and pull her outside. She found herself in the arms of Arkan-tar , who was looking at her with concern.. ;

„Are you okay?„ he asked worriedly, and she shook her head and stood up, looking around. They were in the desert, she could see her companions… Most of them had gone outside….

„How many?„ she said, and Dilayla said in a grim voice…

„Surprising many... Everyone from our team, plus the archduke, the vampire with his daughter, the automaton , and Huntara with Tung-lashor and their weird android...

„And the rest? „ she said, looking at the shocked lizard and warrior.

„ They were paid as a toll. There is always a toll to pay …. „ Kane said…

Chapter End Notes

.Here is another chapter, not my best... I invite you to comment and give your opinion.

Ice Heart - Part One

Chapter Notes

Here's another chapter... Halfway through I realized I forgot about Entrapta. Feel free to leave comments and opinions.

Her face ached from the cold. And also the leg... it had been more thoroughly injured in the last two months than during the entire war, and definitely more seriously, and besides, it wasn't the end yet. She knew that there were more battles ahead of her, more clashes that could cost her much more… Not only her life, but you in the lives of those she cared about… Kyle, Rogelio … And the other former cadets, all of them could pay the highest price for her war… She was afraid of it more than anything in the world. … She would rather lose an arm or a leg than any of them… Although from what I saw, losing an arm or a leg in the galaxy wasn't something that terrible, she had to. After all, she saw how Eti was doing … Or her uncle, who was standing next to her when that girl came. She knew who she was… They had met more than once in the old days on the battlefield… Including quite recently. She saved Kyle and Scarlet... She missed the young sorceress, she didn't want to think about her now... She left, driven by her mysterious desires. She left with Shadow Weaver... But she remembered that she always spoke well of Frosta, so she decided to give the Ice Princess a chance, despite the fact that she could see that Igzar was getting ready to fight, but she was giving him a sign to hold off. And then the girl asked about Shadow Weaver... At first glance, she saw that everything was not good. She was also accompanied by that captain and general Netossa ... And the strange creature she was traveling with... And then Eti appeared with Rosie and said that the dark sorcerer was not here... Frosta was pale, unhealthily pale, but now her face became even whiter... She looked at everyone and asked again.

„Nightgale is here? I mean... Scarlet... Is Scarlett here?„ the girl looked at them pleadingly, and She felt a pang of sadness again.

„She's not here either, she went on a journey with Shadow Weaver... „ she said in a voice sadder than she wanted... Then the Ice Princess fell to her knees and then began to cry... Tears of blood began to flow down your face. At the sight of this, your eyes widened in surprise... Was it some kind of disease...? It was definitely something serious judging by Rosie's face, who covered her mouth and stared pityingly at the Ice Princess, and Eti lowered her gaze. Only Igzar seemed angry.

„Bloodsucker or Corpse Eater… „ He said in a menacing voice…

„If you insult my friend you'll have to deal with me!„ the captain, I think his name was Seahawk and he was Mermista's husband , put his hand on the rapier and the feline warrior tensed to fight, but then General Netossa gave him a sharp look and said.

„That means Nightgale is with her mother... That shouldn't really surprise anyone...„ she sounded gloomy and resigned...„

It took a moment for the meaning of the white-haired woman's words to sink in, and then she felt as if someone had hit her in the face with a hammer...

„What do you mean, her mother? But Scarlett… „ she said, but Frosta interrupted her.

„Scarlett was her friend... At least that's what I think... She's pretending to be her... She took her shape because she knows the right spell... She didn't want anyone to know who she was... Because she's the child of Hordak and Shadow Weaver...„ When the girl said these words, she felt herself sick.. They weren't close friends, at least not as close to me as she was with Rogelio and Kyle ... But they had a slightly different relationship... They even slept together... And now it turned out that she was someone completely different... Someone she didn't know from the records. And on top of that, she was connected to two people who had

hurt them so much... When she looked at it now, it all made sense... She had never trusted her and now she understood where her magical abilities had suddenly come from. She was the one who convinced them to cooperate with the Mi-Go, and that had led to the expedition to the north. In fact, it was thanks to her that they were in this place. She also got along really well with Shadow Weaver from the start. If she had watched things better… If she had been more attentive… Maybe she would have Seen Through it.

„Yes, I understand you, it even shook me, let alone you.„ said the General, and Seahawk added.

„But he must have been really desperate, since...„ he didn't finish, but looked at him expressively, But then Frosta rolled her eyes and said.

„She wasn't created that way, but in a laboratory... And why do you judge her so harshly? That's why she hid who she was, because she knew how you would react... „ The Ice Princess looked at them sharply. She grimaced, because there was some truth in it, but on the other hand, what could she know, about what people were raised... About what was done to them... That couldn't be forgiven so easily... She rubbed her forehead, remembering ... that she was the one who took in Shadow Weaver as advisor... The one who was their tormentor... How could she judge Nightgale in such a case...

„Regardless of who she was... She's not here now... So your whole expedition was in vain... „ She explained in a grave tone, she didn't have the strength to be nice and spare the girl the suffering

Frosta sagged, as if she no longer had the strength to do anything… Meanwhile, General Netossa knelt down next to her, then began to look around…

„What are you guys doing here…„ she asked cautiously, and then Igzar replied with a growling voice.

„It's none of your business... Actually, you should imprison her and the little one, more Hostages will never hurt.

„Fortunately, Dear Uncle, you have nothing to say here... „ Eti said suddenly, her voice a little less dull than usual. „ So please don't meddle in other matters...” and then the cat girl turned to the princess. ”We are here because we want to dig up an ancient ship... No, we don't want to fight the Witch Queen, she is not worthy of being considered an enemy by such a magnificent creature as I am. We want to protect this world from... Well, from the Blonde's relatives... First Ones… They want to destroy this world and probably all others or something like that... „ she said this gently pointing to the glacier looming over them.

Actually, she should be glad that Shadow Weaver wasn't here... Maybe she could control her rage when she only saw her, but it was better that way. She wasn't someone anyone would want to meet willingly. The problem was that her daughter wasn't here either, nor was anyone who could help the Ice Princess. Unfortunately, at this point, all options were running out. She wanted to sit on her ass, and stare blankly ahead, but she knew that you couldn't afford that... She had to think of something, after all, the role of a ruler, general, and also a Mother was to a large extent to always be ready to look for another solution. She took a deep breath and asked.

„That means this is the First Ones' ship, right?„ she looked at the cat girl, with a strangely sad expression on her face. She looked really similar to Catra, and also to their father... The second cat person was called uncle by her... He looked much less human-like than both girls. He didn't make a very good impression on her, but from what she understood, he listened to his relative, probably his niece. The cat girl nodded, and said.

„Probably yes, otherwise no one would want to dig it out from under the ice... We plan to use these very rare Bombs for this... They're really cool if you're not nearby.” she said and then Frosta

understood what she meant. The girl stood up and wiped her bloody tears, then said.

"We can... I can help you... I have the power of ice, so maybe I can somehow break this glacier..." She said cautiously. Catra's sister and Lonnie exchanged a look, and then the Comrade General said.

„If you're able... I'm just not sure why you'd want to do that... We were fighting just two months ago I'll admit I attacked you, and I'm actually sorry for that, but you're still helping me and opposing Glimmer. What's in it for you?”

The girl hesitated before speaking.

„Because something happened when I was hit by that spell. I don't know what it was, but I ended up in a terrible place and there was someone... his name was Charon and he cursed me... I'm turning into something terrible. A living corpse... I have no idea how to stop it... No one knows about it... Except for a certain sorcerer from that place called Xadia ... Have you heard of it?„ The girl asked, and then Catra's sister and Lonnie exchanged a look..

„Ireanis, our alcoholic sorceress, at Grimmys request , went to look for a way to this place, together with captain Wingy and her boyfriend... „ The girl explained it. She had to think for a moment who Grimmy was before she realized who she was talking about.

"That means one damn alcoholic used another damn alcoholic... And wait... Is that captain Queen Angela? What man of hers... Are you talking about her husband?" she said, increasingly confused, and then Seahawk made a delighted face and said.

„But it's wonderfully romantic! A quest for a secret treasure of two lovers who have been separated by time and who now have a chance to fall in love again.”

She noticed that the white-haired girl next to Catra's sister made a delighted face, but the rest looked at Mermista's husband with

consternation.

“Well, you could generally put it that way. So you're going to help us...? „ Lonnie said and then Frosta nodded and said.

„Yes, I will help you... If then you tell me how to get there... „ said the Ice Princess with a sad smile on her face. Well, they had hope, even if so distant.

Lady Ka clenched her cybernetic fist furiously at the sight of this feline brute. How on Galaxy he had survived, she couldn't understand, but it was something that even the Lord Admiral didn't know about... And that was probably the only reason this bastard was still alive. Otherwise, they would have used all the means at the disposal of the Fearless Armada to catch him and kill him permanently this time. Until now, the Shadows had been treated as a potential nuisance, but without their old master, they weren't too dangerous... Now, however, it has come to light that he is alive and, what is more, he is cooperating with their boss's daughter.... The daughter who had torn her face apart... She hated the older one, but tried not to show it… too clearly, but the younger one… knew she couldn't hurt her, but she had ways to hurt her so that even her father wouldn't find out… Although she wasn't sure if the word cooperation was a good description of the relationship between her and her uncle. She saw the cold, warning look she was giving him, and the furious clenching of Pahtra's jaw. She understood who was really in charge... Well, that little bitch had always been mean, meaner even than her uncle, and now she only hoped that at the first opportunity they would kill each other and take the problem off her mind.

But then they mentioned Xadia … She had been there when Lady Sorrowflame and Lady Cali and that ugly Elf were talking and she knew what they were talking about. It was interesting, she was already starting to think about her future, and working with both the beautiful aristocrat and the ancient dragon seemed quite promising… And besides, she liked doing them, and she knew that

with them she had a chance to gain more than with your old commander… Above all, she would no longer have to work with those disgusting cat chimeras…

„That means Shadow Weaver isn't here... But why does my sister still want to work with the rebellion? Has she somehow warped her mind? Or has my uncle deceived her...? „ the Admiral's daughter tore her out of her thoughts. She could hear the desperation in her voice, typical of someone who doesn't want to believe what she sees. Well, she suspected that she was close to discovering the truth, so she had to be on her guard. Her pet shimmers yellow, blue and red, Well, he's confused about what his owner...

„ Apparently, you know, brain hacking and such techniques are very advanced in the galaxy, and then there's the sorcery and the plain old lies...„ She explained. She could already see that no one would be able to hear her now, even if she screamed.

„Now we have to think about what to do anyway... We have to somehow free Frosta and my sister. „ Catra's voice held the desperation of someone who is trying to focus on a simple goal, and we will be thinking too much about what is happening around them. She looked at the glacier that the other group had mentioned, and smiled slyly.

„We can go to that place... Maybe we can surprise them there somehow.”

Shadow Weaver wasn't here... And absolutely no one knew where she was. When she heard that, she wanted to laugh, so hard that Melog looked at her with concern. There was nothing strange about it... She had come here believing that the Dark Sorceress who had enslaved her sister and led the Rebellion along with Lady Cal was somewhere here, but it turned out that she wasn't here, and on top of that, no one even knew where she was, and no one seemed to care. But there were her uncle... According to her

Father, he sold her to the person who sent her to Etheria... No, that wasn't according to her father's words, it was the absolute truth! She couldn't allow herself to believe in these slanders. She had to believe what her father had told her... Especially now... She couldn't allow everything to fall apart right now... Maybe she'd make us all think twice when her sister and Frosta were safe. But not now...

Her sister… She could finally take a closer look at her , relatively close. They were very similar, although she had sharper facial features, and there was something about her… Sad? No, that wasn't the right word… She seemed to be very tired on the surface, as if everything around her was sucking the energy out of her, but at the same time she felt a hidden fire dormant within her… She had felt similarly at the end of the war, and that was why she felt sympathy and compassion for this girl… She would very much like to get to know her better, to be a family. But for that she had to get her out of here. Which wouldn't be easy. Her uncle was here with all the soldiers, not even counting the rebels. She didn't try to find out what the reasons were for her sister working with someone like that She wanted to believe that he was somehow pressuring her, but she could see that their relationship was much more like what had happened between her and Hordak after she had shown him his place. She should learn more, but she feared that she didn't have the time.

She didn't understand why Frosta and Netossa had agreed to help them... She had heard them mentioning that planet... Maybe they needed to know how to get there... Or maybe the general wanted to create a ruse to take over the ship... Either way, they had made the whole thing difficult... Or maybe not, after all it would be easier for her to intercept all four, or rather five, if they only made it to the glacier. That was why they had to get there first. Fortunately, thanks to Melog's power , as well as the general chaos, they were practically undetectable, so with a minimum of caution, they could get there faster than the others, especially since they didn't have to hurry so much. She wasn't exactly happy about traveling with Lady Ka, who had decided to take these particular subordinates with her. Of all the ones she had, who

seemed like the biggest thugs she didn't want to turn her back on. But there was one thing she could trust the Lord Admiral's left hand with, this woman hated her uncle with a hatred as hot as the heart of the sun.

They got closer to the glacier. Now she could see the vastness of the thing trapped inside it better. She could see the large spaceships, all too well, but it was also the second largest after Velvet Glove … If this was really a ship of the First Ones… She flew on board the Darla, but it was a small ship, a research and transport ship or something like that … And this one was bigger than the largest warships of the Horde… If Shadow Weaver and her allies took it… It could lead to the destruction of them all… Only, this was the work of that ancient damned civilization… How could anyone be so naive as to believe that they could take control of it? And why would they want to do that? She heard them talking about some great threat that everyone believed in, probably even the queen...She remembered what Lady Cala had told her when they had interrogated her, about the First Ones and that They were planning Revenge… She would have considered her words if it had been anyone else. But this was a psychopathic bitch who was happy to hurt and manipulate them… Was she here, or had she learned that tale from Shadow Weaver… She didn't know , and she had no idea what to think… Yet something deep inside her warned her. What if it was true, even if only in part? They all knew all too well what that civilization could do… They had seen for themselves that they had annihilated the original inhabitants of Etheria … What more could they do?

They started climbing… the glacier was steep, but it wasn’t an ice wall. She and Melog had no trouble climbing up. Lady Ka and This Insectoid kept up with her, which was a bit surprising since the woman didn't seem like someone who liked physical exertion Their other companions weren't faring so well, but she was hopeful they would get there eventually.. It was windy and cold here, but she didn’t really feel it. She was too focused on her mission. She could see the ship hidden under the ice better and better. It was massive, but at the same time it seemed beautiful… As if she had made one not only for war, but also to admire it. She saw the

Crystal Castle and a few of their other buildings and couldn’t deny they were beautiful. But beauty meant nothing… Lady Cala had proven that to them all perfectly.

What was more disturbing, however, was that the ship looked virtually undamaged… Like it had been trapped here just before takeoff. She thought about the power Frosta wielded and wondered if the Princesses had already wielded runestones back then? That was a disturbing thought, one that would probably interest Entrapta much more … She found herself uneasily at a loss as to how to free her, and it would be very difficult to get her to leave this ship alone. She had always loved technology, and she remembered Adora's stories about how hard it had been to get her off the Beast Island… Of course, her relationship with the rest of her friends was much better now… She also guessed that the woman must be near the ship.

Eventually they climbed to the top of the Glacier, where the upper sections of the ship were jutting out. She could see that they were made of metal covered in a crystalline substance. She recognized several of the objects as point defense cannons, and had learned a bit about space ships during her time on Velvet. Glove … She couldn’t tell the purpose of the other objects, though, and she wasn’t sure anyone else could. The upper layer of the glacier was much flatter, and they started climbing up, but the wind was blowing right into their eyes, so she had to pull her hood up. So, she saw three figures at one of the thicker spots in the family. One was a silver-scaled lizard, and the other a red-haired girl with a lot of strange amulets pinned to her clothes. She recognized both of them from the descriptions she had been given by their humming. They were tinkering with something that looked like a heavy metal cylinder, and the third was… Entrapta! She smiled at the sight, and having ordered Melog to remove the cloaking field, she called out.

„Entrapta! What are you doing here!?”

Princess inventor She turned to her side smiling broadly and said.

„Oh! Catra! Great that you're here! We're just assembling here...„ Suddenly fear appeared on her face... „Watch out!„ she called out, and she heard Lady Ka curse behind her, but before she could react, shots were fired

Ice Heart - Part Two

She was tired… This was already the fourth Journey through the Void that day, and it must have taken a negative toll on her body, and yet it was not the Last Journey that she would take any time soon. On the other hand… Her body had been forced to endure such terrible things…. Now it probably didn’t make any difference…. She took a deep breath, drawing cold air into her cybernetic lungs… The wind blew her dark red hair… Ivi stood next to her, hugging her. She smiled at the android and looked around They were on top of a cliff, where they had a great view of everything around them. She could see the tall mountains stretching out in the eye, but her vision showed more…… She could sense an ancient city stretching out beneath her feet. No, there were two cities. One was so old that the other was created just to study it, it was quite amusing, but she hadn't come here to study the remains of ancient civilizations . She was only looking for a few quite modern people... However, one of them was a product of a civilization that had left its mark on this place. She could see a military camp in the distance. Her cybernetic eyes allowed her to see more than she could if she had her own... She saw flags, some she didn't recognize, but the rest belonged to the Shadows of Tarak . It was interesting, it would certainly be good if her father found out about it... However, they were not his priority at the moment, let alone hers. She looked at what towered above the camp, and smiled, sincerely and with joy. To see such an artifact of the First Ones... Her hands itched. This could be a big problem after all... Or not, there would be something to study, which would again postpone her possibility of rest for an indefinite period... She sighed, but she didn't complain. One day she will find peace... She saw a few dots moving up ice slope and when she enlarged it she smiled to herself... After so many years... She finally saw her... The one who gave her a name... the one she loved and hated. She felt a surge of feelings that was hard to define... She wasn't sure if she should meet her, at least not now.

Ivi hugged her tightly with one hand, sensing what was hidden in her heart, and she returned the hug, and then she started looking around. She saw a few other figures higher up. One of them was a clone of Jantar, probably Lady Ka Judging by the fact that she wore a mask on half of her face... However, the second person... The second person was that sister... At the sight of her she smiled to herself, and it was a very, very bad smile. She had never imagined, even in her dreams, which she no longer knew, that she would meet all three in such a short space of time. It was a sign from... destiny

„Well, we'll meet again, little sister... I'll show you what pain and loss are... You'll learn to be strong like me.„ She said in a quiet and strange voice... For now, she'll wait and see how the events unfold, and then... And then she'll put her plan into action...

Eti had to restrain herself from brushing against Rosie… Something in the back of her mind told her that this was very catty behavior, but she didn't care. She loved her so much… She wanted to smell her scent on her, and for her to smell of her… They felt so good in the cabin… She regretted that they couldn't spend more time just lying next to each other, but it wasn't their last time… They would have more opportunities to wake up next to each other… All their lives… She allowed herself a small smile and walked over to her girlfriend, brushing her shoulder against hers anyway. Rosie blushed like a beetroot, and kissed her on the cheek. No one paid attention to them... Apparently everyone had bigger problems... Actually, everyone really did have bigger problems... Smarty went with Lilka and Alatar to the top of the glacier, to check where they could make rock incinerators. Whitehead and Icy came to that... It really was getting harder to give people decent names in this place. And they brought Hawkey with them, too… The latter one really looks like someone they could practice deadly combos with , but the other two seemed nice... Icy must have had something terrible happen to her... She could smell the stench of death emanating from her... She had nothing against the undead... After all, she had once slept with Dr.

Sidonius' daughter , but... She knew that this girl had been done this… thing, and it was all against her will. In a way, she identifies with her. She looked nice, gave the impression of someone who had incredible skills in diplomacy with her fists... A healthy display of pacifism... As for the Whitehead, she didn't know what to make of her, but she seemed okay... From what she'd heard, she was some kind of general... She was starting to meet a lot of people in high positions... She should probably consider becoming a politician, she would make a really great president or other dictator. She had to organize an election campaign and stuff like that... She'd do it!

They were taking their time heading towards the glacier, they probably had a few days before anyone realized they were there. And besides, as Scar had said, this place was outside the Witch Queen's rule, so they couldn't just bring it in and shoot it at them... I mean, she wouldn't have a problem with that either, but from what she knew, that wasn't how politics worked. She was a little worried about what they would do after it was that ship from under the ice... Really, she wasn't good at planning anything... As she considered all the options and possibilities her mind… Wandered deep areas hidden beyond her consciousness. Reached the places where she was forced with knowledge she never wanted to have… Given to fill a role she hated… Their father had chosen a destiny for her, but she would never accept it! Never!

Rosie hugged her, she probably sensed that she was thinking about something unpleasant and she hugged her back, but then she had to let go of her because they started climbing up the ice. It was slippery here, but she could climb and she had shoes with their own gravitational field, and she had an idea so transformed the fingers of her metal hand into claws, which she dug into the ice. But then she suddenly smelled... Someone had been climbing here, and only recently... The smell was... Familiar... Familiar and foreign at the same time... It was her scent, or rather someone similar to her. For a moment she didn't know what it could be, and then the communicator went off and she heard a voice.

„Eti! Could you come over here and talk to your sister so she'll stop acting silly and cooperate with Ladh. Ka? „ Alatar called out and they all looked at each other and then she said.

„ I'm going first!... Rosie, come on „ she said to her girlfriend. Together they ran towards the top of the glacier...

She looked back to see that Lady Ka had drawn her weapon, as had her insectoid subordinate, and both of them began firing at Entrapta and her companions.

„Are you crazy? You could hit Entrapta … We didn't come to shoot anyone!” she shouted angrily, pulling out her claws.

"I'll explain later!" Her father's left hand woman shouted, not even looking in her direction, then jumped out of the way as the Silver Scale Lizard fired a powerful energy beam. The half-masked woman jumped to the side, and rolled across the ice, digging the sharp metal claws of her cybernetic hand into it. Her insect companion fired twice quickly at the reptile at the armor, causing splinters to fly, but it didn't seem to hurt him seriously.

„You have to stop! I order you!„ She yelled at Lady Ka but the woman ignored her and stood behind the cower and continued firing. At that moment she realized that she was between two groups firing at each other, although the second one was mostly the lizard. The red-haired girl pulled out her axe and charged at Shirren, trying to take him down with more blows, while Entrapta… was still hiding near the lizard. She knew her friend hated violence, but why was she hiding with the other group? She was naive and honest, but she was happy when she saw her, she was scared only when she saw Lady Ka… understanding burned in her mind, like a white flame. She remembered that the woman in the half-mask was the last person to see Entrapta before the kidnapping, and only she and her subordinates told them what happened then… She was torn from her stupor caused by doubts by an energetic Bolt, which might have hit her, but fortunately

Melog Pushed her away, thanks to which the burning energy only brushed her body. She disappeared again, but this time only she and Melog, and looked around. More of Lady Ka's subordinates began to arrive and joined the fight. Grag charged at the girl with an axe, trying to hit her with his war hammer, and the large dog-like creature grabbed some kind of energy rifle and started shooting at the lizard, who seemed to be calling for help. She had to try to disarm them all, especially Lady Ka's subordinates, but that was easier said than done. She tripped the canine creature, ripped the rifle out of his hands, and hit him hard in the head with the butt, not caring what harm she could do him, and then fitted the barrel so that it could not be used. Then she moved towards the insectoid it clattered with irritation, and began shooting in her direction. It was true that he did not see her, but he did not have to, because he simply shot with a fan, hoping that one of the bullets would hit her... Now she understood completely that Lady Ka was not on her side. Then two more people jumped out over the edge of the ice, but when she looked back she saw her sister and the white-haired girl, who shone with a delicate light reminiscing about how her wife was when she became She-Ra, but with her it was more white and somehow colder. She jumped towards Grag and grabbed his hammer by the handle, when Ted took a swing, and when you threw yourself towards her, she practically effortlessly tore it from his hands and threw it far away, so he started to slowly retreat, but the redhead Hit him with the flat. At that time, her sister moved towards Lady

Ka, but then the insectoid aimed two pistols, so she jumped at him and knocked him down, and Melog jumped on his back and growled, pressing, and then removed the invisible curtain from them. The white-haired looked in her direction and, smiling, waved her hand, and her sister glanced at her through and said.

„Howdy!„ and jumped towards the woman in the half-mask. Lady Ka fired twice and once hit the armor that the girl was strangling, but the bullet only peaked, and the cat-like girl twisted her wrist, knocking the weapon out of her hand, but then the Lord Admiral's subordinate pulled out metal claws from the fingers of her cybernetic hand and bit the girl, wounding her in the left arm. Her

sister hissed and And then the fingers of her metal hand transformed into claws long as daggers, and smiling she said.

„Now I have claws again... Remember what happened last time... „ she said approaching her slowly. She wanted to help the girl, but then the white-haired one approached her and put her hand on her shoulder and shook her head. Up close she was quite pretty, and she smelled this scent from her very similar to the one from Adora after they made love... So it's more of a smoky scent very similar to hers...

„Well, I think it's time to talk, little pretty kitty, right?" Lady Ka said and laughed evilly, and then her sister came at her with her claws. She still wanted to intervene, but it seemed that this was her sister's fight. The cat girl tried to tear the clone woman to pieces, but she deftly dodged and dealt blows herself, laughing and mocking her.

„Oh yes, unleash your murderous nature. After all, you've been a killer practically since birth, haven't you?„ She said and rolled over when the girl tried to hit her with her claws, and then tried to stab her with the Knife hidden in her other hand in the stomach. However, her sister grabbed her by the arm and threw her to the ground, trying to break her shoulder, but Mrs. Ka broke free from her grip and jumped further back. Her other companions were overpowered, and she was not sure if the large canine would survive. He was not doing well, because she might have damaged his brain…

„Do you remember the first time you killed…" Said Clone woman and suddenly threw away the weapon and sheathed her claws. "You killed a defenseless person, like me now… I saw the recording, you shot her in the head…" She laughed cruelly, and Catra saw the pain on the face of the other cat girl.

„What are you talking about? „ she asked, unsure of what this could be about, although she was starting to guess... She remembered her stay on Horde Prime's ship, when he tried to break her in a similar way...

„You see Big Kitty, our dear father had a wonderful idea. He had to test the goods before they were delivered to the customer... He had to find out if his little kitties were capable of bearing the burden of the fate they had been given... We were also tested in a similar way... But not always and not so severely... He brought three in debt and gave the little kitties a gun in their hands... And do you know what they were told then? Kill or be killed! That was the order! And do you know what your little sister did? She shot that woman... The Debtor who, well, was late in paying back her debt... It doesn't matter who she was, after all, what matters is what that little animal did, right? I've seen the recordings, and I have to admit that she hesitated... For a moment... But our nature always wins, right?„ as she spoke the younger cat girl hesitated and curled up in on herself, she became smaller, not as threatening as before... She started looking at all of them, as if looking for support until finally her eyes fell on her and then she looked down.

„I didn't want to! They told me to do it... I had to! Otherwise I would have died... Just like them... You understand, it's true...„ Tears started to flow down her face, and then Lady Ka pulled out a gun and aimed it at her sister and then fired. She jumped to protect the girl from the projectile but she knew it was too late, but then a wall of ice rose in front of her. She turned around and saw a smiling Frosta, who climbed up the mountain with the help of Shogi, who turned his tentacles into hooks, and immediately wrapped Lady Ka in ice. The woman tried to break free, but then she just laughed , and said.

„Well, I know, I have to say that the little kitty won. But still a murderer like me... Your heart is ice, and it won't warm! Your soul is as cold as the heart of winter! „ and she laughed.

At that moment her sister began to slowly approach Lady Ka, who was smiling nastily… She knew what the girl wanted to do. She jumped at her and said.

„Don't do this! This is not an option! It will shatter you!„ she said, standing in the girl's way, but she smiled, and it was the first smile

she had seen on her face.

„You see, little sister, I am already shattered... I was shattered a long time ago... „ She said, and then her hand transformed into a sickle blade and she took another step... But then Rosie stood next to her, and took her gently by the forearm... The girls exchanged glances, and then her sister deflated and said.

„I don't want to hurt you... Not long ago I would have, but now... Now stay here and freeze.”

Then Frosta ran up to her and hugged her.

„Oh, I'm so glad to see you! You... You came for me?„ She said with surprise, so she smiled and stroked her head, ignoring the strange smell she smelled from her.

„I had to go get you because I thought Shadow Weaver was here... „ she said without holding back her tears, and then her sister spoke up, her voice as dull as always.

„But she's not here... You all keep looking for her here, but she's gone... And she definitely has her own things to deal with...„ She stood up, walked up to the woman in the half mask and said, addressing her, Not Lady Ka.

„Grimmy was your Lady Ka, right?”

She closed her eyes because she knew that what she was going to say now would not only be about her sister's relationship with the clone woman, but would also be an admission that the stories about her father might be true.

„Yes...„ she finally answered, feeling the pain in her heart. Adrenaline was still pumping through her veins, so for now she could ignore the blade stabbing her soul, but she knew that everything would calm down… That then she would have to face the truth. Everyone started to me, until after a moment Lonnie and Netossa came upstairs with Seahawk and her uncle. The general smiled at her, and said.

„And yet it is true, you came here!„ she said, and the captain put his hand on her shoulder and said

„It's great that you're here, although you could have waited for me to fight.„ He pointed at Lady Ka's fallen subordinates. She smiled, then looked at her Uncle, who was watching her with concern in his eyes.

„You see, you are outnumbered now, uncle, so even if you were planning something stupid, you've already lost..„ said her sister and looked at her... „ By the way, Hi... I'm Eti... „ she said, and after a moment, as if remembering something, she extended her hand towards her, the living, left one.

„And I'm Catra... And I'm so glad to see you.„ she said using all her willpower, so as not to fall apart... She knew her problems were only just beginning, but for now she just had to be happy that she could finally meet her sister.

„And I'm Rosie... And I'm your sister's girlfriend... I'm so sorry I attacked your wife... I'd have to explain a lot to you, and I don't know all of it myself, but I'll try to make sure it never happens again...„ said white-haired girl She lowered her head, and her sister hugged her, and at that moment Melog walked up to her and started rubbing himself against her.

„She will surely understand that... We have such events behind us. „ She smiled, recalling a few of the worst moments in her and her wife's life...

„So now we have to first Excavate this ship, right?„ Netossa interrupted, looking uncertainly at everything that was hidden under the ice.

„I guess so, What do you think, Will you be able to break this ice? - Eti said turning to Frosta, and the ice princess nodded after thinking.

„It probably shouldn't even be that hard... "She looked towards Lady Ka and said "What are we going to do with her? Because if

she sits in this ice for too long, she might freeze to death, you know?„ she said, and then her sister answered.

“Then she should pray to the more lousy of gods that we will finish examining this ship as soon as possible.”

„If I freeze here, you'll never know what happened to your sisters...” Lady Ka asked, tilting her head to the side...

„Sisters? What is she talking about?„ she said, and then Eti lowered her gaze.

„It doesn't matter, they're dead anyway!„ she said but the woman in the half mask laughed.

„Oh, do you really believe that? Maybe it was easier for you that way. But you want our father-creator, you know that bringing you into being wasn't easy at all, and someone so enterprising probably wouldn't want to waste such a large amount of money invested resoureces... He sold them and if you want to know Who... Well, you have to free me... „ she said, focusing the eyes of everyone present on her.

„You know that if I wanted to, I could get It out of you, and in a very unpleasant way.„ said her sister in a very flat voice approaching the clone woman...

„ Of course! You're just as capable as I am. You just don't want to show your real face to your newfound sister? And besides, I'm not sure if you have enough time.„ she said and waited with a smile on her face. Eti seemed very tired, so she made a decision for her .

„Okay Frosta, take off that ice... But that doesn't mean you're free!„ As she said those words, the ice would crumble, and the clone woman began to massage her arms, then looked behind her back and said.

"Perfect timing..." she said, a smile appearing on the visible half of her face.

"You don't look that cold..." Netossa said glumly, but Lady Ka pointed behind her.

„I'm talking about my dogs...„ she said, and then they saw the missiles coming from the horizon.

Itel hated that she hadn't fully recovered yet... She wanted to go with the rest when the alarm went off, but she was politely told to guard the ship along with that strange droid and Mr. Ilemshaw ... The worst part of it all was that she now had too much time to think... Thinking about everything that had happened in the last few months... About the Shadows of Tarak and what consequences their arrival had. She had no idea that Eti's uncle was alive, and that he would want to take control of the rebellion She knew he was an unpleasant person, after all she remembered him well, but... Well, she remembered him well, she should have guessed what he was planning... She wasn't stupid, but she was blinded by hatred and the desire for revenge... If it weren't for Eti pacifying him... Everyone would be at his command now... She was grateful to him for helping save them during the swarm invasion, and then thanks to him they found Shelter and so on... However, she knew that she wasn't objective. She saw him as a hero who had saved them, while Eti was aware that everything he had done was just a preparation for further war with the Lord Admiral. Besides, he had changed over the years. He had become more furious and unyielding, and his determination had turned into fanaticism. He had even accepted that he needed cybernetic implants, which he had previously hated. Of course, it had not helped him much when Eti had forced obedience from him. She had not expected that her… friend would be able to do something like that. She wondered if she had already guessed that she was calling the Shadows. It was then that she realized who this girl really was. She was not just a Warrior, but she had been created for something more. A destiny had been chosen for her, which she had rejected.

Of course, there was also the matter of Eti and Rosie. She had already accepted that they were together, but it still hurt when she looked at them… So she had to accept what had happened. And figure out a way to move on, but what? Truth be told, she had recently lost her purpose in life… She had simply started to go with the flow. As she sat in the training room trying to move her aching arm, she heard Eti's voice over the communicator.

„Raise all ships! We're being attacked by Lady Ka's dogs and who knows who else."

She nodded to herself and ran to put on her gear when suddenly she felt the glacier hit something…

A few honest words

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

As soon as she saw who had visited them, she decided not to interfere. For now, it was all above her head anyway. She wasn't, at least officially, part of the People's Rebellion Command, and she had no reason to push herself into these negotiations. They were locals, and she had already gotten to know them well enough to know that her talents wouldn't be very useful... Besides, it would be good to give these girls some freedom and a chance to regain their Self”Confidence. Actually, it was only about Lonnie, because of course Eti had no problem with that, at least not in this way... She still thought she had been right when she had said those harsh words to Comrade General, but now it was worth it to make her feel a little better thanks to achieving some success. She also sent Lilka to Alatar, so that together they could slowly install explosives for this strange inventor princess. She was basically left alone with Wrongdak ... Which was her goal, but Unfortunately, this talkative horse followed them, looking for some sort of comfort. He tried to stay discreetly in the back, but wasn't very good at it... Finally she sighed and said.

„Come here… Because if you keep following us around, I'll just feel like I'm, you know, being followed, and believe me, it's annoying as hell.„ when she turned to face him, he had a very surprised expression on his face...

„How on Etheria did you spot me? I thought I blended in perfectly!„ he called out and she sighed heavily and said.

„We're in a military camp, and you are winged horse with horn… how on galaxy can you blend in here?„ she said, not sure if she was more nervous or shocked.

„I've often been to military camps, and people usually didn't notice me there.„ he said in a very careful voice, and she could barely keep herself from rolling her eyes and telling him how things really were.

„ Oh it will pass and no one would ever follow anyway because we are all trained to sense when someone is trying to sneak up on us and we are very good at sneaking… Although I don't like it.„ Wrongdak explained, somehow calming the worm down.

„And why are you following us? From what I saw, Catra and a few of your other friends came there, and besides, you could go with Lilka... She would definitely enjoy your company.„ She said, hoping in her heart that she would be able to convince him and she would be able to focus on implementing her plan...

„Because I'm a little... I'm a little ashamed to show myself in front of my friends... Theoretically I should arrest you, somehow it turned out that I'm a little bit of a prisoner... You know, I was supposed to be She-Ra's faithful steed and companion and I guess I got a little lost.„ He lowered his head, and she barely controlled herself so that resignation wouldn't appear on her face... This could take longer than she thought. Wrongdak smiled and approached Aricorn , and stroked his mane.

„ Fear not, you are a perfect steed worthy of She-Ra herself…" she said, and the horse nodded, but then she couldn't hold back.

" And even if you don't, so what? You can't let your... Let's say your profession define you! You can be anything you want!" she said with more irritation and anger than she intended.

"It defines me, actually . This is what I was created for..." Swiftwind explained sadly, and she blinked as she felt confused.

„In what sense? I mean, what do you mean when you say you were created?"

The horse lowered his head and explained.

“Because You know, I was just a Horse not so long ago, but then Adora transformed me… And then I gained my reason. At first I didn't understand what was happening to me, but even then I saw that my role was to be She-Ra's mount… And for a while it worked, but then… then she flew into space, and then she found Catra, and then so much changed and now I'm basically… Well, basically useless…” he saidwith her head down, And she felt that she was becoming a horse”like creature, so she said.

„To be honest, it's not fair how they treated you... You didn't ask to gain reason in a world as fucked as this... It will certainly be hard for you to say but to really think about finding your own future... You can't just be... Well, a thinking mount. „ she approached and stroked the creature's neck, in a way feeling a connection with him... They were both brought into being as tools of much more powerful beings and it didn't matter so much that She-Ra was on the side of good, while her father-Creator was a crazy egocentric. Either way, they were bound by the role they were forced into. It was undoubtedly horrible and in a way tragic. She could have simply rebelled against whoever created her, but that aricorn was forever tied to its mistress… He was a magical creature, how could he defy the power that had called him into existence? She sighed seeing the sadness on the mount's muzzle and began to wonder if she shouldn't change her plans… The decision had been made for her… An alarm sounded, announcing that an enemy was approaching… Did it have anything to do with what was happening on the glacier? Maybe some monsters had emerged from the ruins of the city, or, most likely...

"How well do you fly with two passengers? And two who've never been on a mount before?" she asked Swiftwind , and he hesitated and said

„I have transported strangers and inexperienced people, and a lot of them at once... But you probably don't think about... What are you thinking about, actually.

„I'm thinking of something very unwise... „ she said looking at the horizon... And then the sound of an explosion shook everything...”

"What the hell is that?" Netossa shouted, summoning an energy shield just as the first missile hit them. The entire glacier shook , so she turned to Frosta .

„Are you able to hold it together?„ by this she meant the entire glacier. The ice princess nodded thoughtfully, and then her eyes lit up light blue and the shaking glacier stopped moving… Then the girl made another gesture with her hands and then an ice wall began to form around them, covering her energy shield. They were safe… She would see her children… She breathed a sigh of relief. Then she looked at Lady. Ka and her subordinates. The woman in the half-mask smiled mockingly.

"You planned this from the start..." Catra said, her voice laced with anger. Lady Ka chuckled and said absolutely.

„Of course not, only since the moment I saw Shadows of Tark... I only expected that I would somehow manage to neutralize the smaller kitty earlier, and present you with a fait accompli... You might be angry, but I'm sure that your father would explain it all to you so nicely that you would believe everything... Abandoned kittens always yearn for their owner, isn't that right?„ when she said this she seemed absolutely calm and amused, and she had the impression that the rage she saw on Catra's face only cheered up the woman in the half mask ... She knew that the Great Marshal was on the verge of an explosion. Or rather a breakdown. She had to help her focus on the current problems in some way.

"Can you order them to stop firing?„ She asked and then Lady Ka looked as if she was thinking and said.

„Maybe so, but why? Better to die in battle than rot in a dungeon somewhere, even a luxurious one like the one you locked that Ugly elf in…„ she said and then the shield shook again, because they must have hit them directly, but it held, although only because the ice created by Frosta took most of the force of the

explosion . Then Catra's sister... This Eti approached the Lord Admiral's seccond-in-command and tilted her head.

„We can always go back to our previous plan... „ She said in a quiet and menacing voice... There was something scary about this girl... She knew that Catra was capable of terrible things when she served in the Horde, after all she almost killed them all when she opened the portal, and also sent Entrapa to the Beast Island. But there was something... different about this other girl. Catra did bad things because she gave in to her impulses... And Eti had the impression that someone had to remind herself that it was not allowed to hurt others... She wasn't sure if she would be willing to leave her children with her...

"I think we've already had this discussion... Do we really have to go back to the same thing? Just let me go... And my subordinates, an then we'll manage somehow...she said and was absolutely Calm. Golden eyes with blue flecks flashed with cold anger, and it was hard to tell what Eti would do next, but then Catra spoke up.

„I agree... but you probably shouldn't even expect any mercy from my father... You made me see him for who he is... „ Catra said gloomily, but the clone woman smiled contemptuously and spoke in cheerful tones.

„We'll see, maybe I have an alternative prepared, And besides, we'll see what truth Lord Admiral... Truth is relative after all. Do you agree, kitty?„ she said looking at Eti, who tilted her head to the side, measuring her very much with this look, but immediately after that Lady Ka began to untie her subordinates, although she had to kick the big dog-like creature twice before it stood up, what a horrible army, both the commander and the soldiers. Then she headed beyond the barrier, but before she did anything, Eti took a large rifle off her back and aimed from her hip at the Lord Admiral's deputy and said.

"Do what you have to do… Or let me hurt you…" Her voice was eerily calm and devoid of any emotion, she sounded like a tired

mother asking her children not to make noise… Somehow she had the impression that it worked better than yelling.

„Okay, I'll do whatever it takes. „ she turned on the communicator and asked a few short orders, and after a few minutes the gunfire subsided.

„ So that's it... Can I go now? „ she said in a slightly bored voice and then Lonnie asked.

„What guarantees do we have that you won't change your mind before you evacuate her?”

„The same as the fact that you won't start firing at you until my men leave... But let me guarantee you that despite everything I'd rather survive, and it's really easy to die during artillery fire... “she said in a bored voice , and the fellow general snorted.

“Alright, I'll order my men to hold their fire too... „ she said, looking at the half-masked woman... And then she started giving orders herself. The fire from the People's Rebellion had stopped, if there had been any, so the half-masked woman smiled and headed for the dome made of ice and power grid.

" Maybe it's time you made an ice crossing or something?" she said, but then Catra walked up to her and demanded it.

“You said I had some other sisters... You'd better tell me right away what happened to them.„ When she said that Lady. Ka laughed and started talking with a nasty smile on her face.

„Well, the first one was to weak... You see she didn't kill anyone, she just curled up in the corner and cried... From the beginning she was big and pathetic, despite being the strongest of them all, but that's not what the Lord Admiral needed, she'll be useful to the scientists. I don't know the details, but from what I've heard your genetic line is exceptionally interesting... „ She mentioned it Eti and her quite charming girlfriend exchanged glances. „So he sold her to a certain government lab on Kesler ...„ And when that name was mentioned Eti and her friends paled, and the white-

haired girl hugged her. Catra frowned, and said slowly as if she realized something terrible.

"Wasn't this place destroyed?" she said, and then the girl's uncle laughed in a boastful way and said

„ Yeah, the Swarm ate him... I was there when it happened... I saved a lot of people, those were fucking good times.”

She saw the grand marshal stagger, and Melog took on the blue-green hues of sadness, even despair…

„ As for the second one… She didn’t resist the order to execute him, and she shot the debtor right away. But that didn’t sit well with our father-creator either. I think he thought your Lord Admiral didn’t need such a psychopath as his heir, but I think he simply knew that such a wild creature would be completely uncontrollable… So he sent her to Apostate…”

Then she saw Eti and her friends looking at the clone woman in horror. She wasn't sure what to think of that, since the news that one girl had landed on a planet devoured by some Swarm hadn't caused such a reaction... What was the Apostate?

“You're a monster.„ Catra's sister said, but Lady Ka just giggled and said.

„There are many monsters in this place, no worse than me. Not to mention our kitties, who else do you have... Girl who is corpse-eater, or aa warcriminal? But you can't blame me for what happened to your sisters . After all, it was our creator's doing... You have to thank him in hell... “She approached the barrier with her subordinates, and together with Frosta , who looked paler than before, created a passage through which Lady Ka and her subordinates emerged. When she was already outside, however, she stopped, as if remembering something, and took off her mask... She inhaled loudly, feeling the cold sweat of pure terror appear on her face. Catra fell to her knees, and her sister and her girlfriend had to hold her up. Seahawk drew his rapier, and

Frosta's claws came out of her fingers. It turned out that where the emeralds were, there were Three eyes where Horde Prime had his. They were completely green and dead, but the resemblance was obvious.

„You see, your father once captured several ships from Horde Prime , about thirty-five years ago... And passed them on to our Fathe-creator... So we came from the same technology as the mad tyrant... „ Lady Ka said, smiling predatorily and looked at the Great Cat Man . „ If you were worried about not succeeding in taking my life, you had no reason to, I really did die then, but my soul and consciousness were stored in some device, and then I was revived. Only, the damn thing got stuck and kept trying to recreate me with those three eyes. Probably, it thought it was cloning a new body for that mad idiot... And now, see you later!„ and she started to retreat with her people. Soon they disappeared behind the rocks.

„Frosta, help us dig up this ship, because I have a feeling that I'll soon be receiving gunfire. All she needs is a chance to survive.„ she said anxiously, looking up.

"I need to go to my people, they need me!" Lonnie said and exited through the same hole that the mad woman had exited through. As she took a few steps, her staff flashed and she teleported Down…

„This staff is weird... „ she muttered quietly, and then Frosta dug her fingers into the ice.

Lady Ka cursed under her breath, because she knew that her situation was shitty… She had done exactly what she had been forbidden to do… Antares wouldn't just be furious, he would get rid of her… If she’s lucky, he’ll do it quickly… And if not… He certainly had other specialists in advanced interrogation techniques… And if not, he would find them quickly… And to be honest, she didn't blame him… She should have refused that cat-

like girl, and then nothing would have happened… She would have gone here with the queen after all and… And then everything would have gone the same way... She should have planned it differently, maybe come to an agreement with Lady Sorrowflame and carry out the operation herself, And like this... And like this they were in deep shit… She ordered her men to stop and stood herself, leaning her back against the stone wall… Her subordinates gathered around her, but they were intelligent enough not to say anything… She had to think everything through… She had to plan how to get out of all this… She had to…

She then heard someone jump down from above onto the snow-covered ice, followed closely by a second person, not so gracefully. All of her so-called soldiers drew their weapons, and she opened her eyes. She saw a woman in front of her with hair of a very familiar shade of red, and next to her a whole android around which were floating in metal balls.

„Who the fuck are you?„ Graag said swinging his hammer, but then she saw an incredibly fast flash, then blood spurted out and Graag's hand fell off. The Duergar started screaming, and then the newcomer took off her mask. At the sight of her face she burst into hysterical laughter.

„This has to be some kind of joke!„ she exclaimed, and the cat-like girl with metal eyes and a sweaty face smiled exceptionally predatorily.

„Well, my name is Smiley so it's no wonder people laugh when they see me. And what's even funnier is that I'm now the second in command of Lord Protector Antares, really funny, isn't it?„ when she said that, she moved her blade to her throat in one quick movement. Lady Ka looked around at her subordinates, but she knew very well that none of them would risk it to save her... Maybe that was a good thing, because they would make her a head shorter.

„ And you came here... You probably didn't want to give some grand speech about the superiority of felines, did you? You don't

really want to kill me, and in a moment my men will start shooting. She said because in fact her orders were hidden that they should continue shooting in a few minutes. She might die as a result of it, but there is a chance that at least one of the cats dies.

"Well, now I'll take charge... But it might come in handy... I think my little sisters saw who our daddy is..." She tilted her head to the side, as if considering something, then said. "For a moment I considered killing you, but I think it might come in handy for my friends... You're cunning, and you have skills that are as useful as ever... I hope you like retro adventures?"

Chapter End Notes

I invite you to comment on this chapter and express your opinions.

Darkstar

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She clenched her teeth, now sharp and longer than they should have been, she didn’t paid attention to this. She had to concentrate with all her might. She had never used her power on such a scale before. She knew it would be hard, but she had to do it. Everyone was counting on her… She heard the ice crumble beneath her, everything began to tear, so at the same time she had to try to hold it together, which was not easy at all! She had to count in the layers of ice with her mind and find the ones that had to be destroyed and the ones that had to remain standing to support this ship. She knew she was glowing bright blue, but that did not matter now, she had to deal with this as soon as possible.

„Well, fuck, they finally started shooting.„ Netossa said with Fury in her voice, and then she heard an explosion, although none of them hit.

„They don't shoot as hard as before... Could it be that she doesn't want to kill us?„ Catra's sister said in that strange voice of hers...

„Or maybe I'm planning something worse, people like her always have a few plans in reserve... I know something about that.„ Catra answered her and the other girl nodded.

Even though they hadn't been shot at yet, it was still crazy and I had to put in more effort to keep it in one piece. Shogi held her up tightly, so she could stop focusing on keeping her balance and just focus on her task. She finally penetrated deep into the glacier and found a few places where she could thicken it to better support such a massive thing, but near them she crumbled it and one of the ship's sides was exposed.

"Okay, Entrapta will look for an entrance once more... Do you need help?" Catra said, looking at her with concern, but she smiled so that her teeth couldn't be seen and said.

„No need! Everything is perfectly fine.„ said Lying, because she was already starting to feel a slight hunger and was certain that only meat would satisfy it. She wore a fur coat on top, but she wasn't as thickly dressed as she should be for such weather, which wasn't visible, but she wasn't cold anyway. She looked at the ship and felt a strange tingling sensation when she saw it. It reminded them of the place she and Nightgale were trapped in… This ship was strangely similar. She only hoped that there was nothing Dangerous lurking inside, nor any terrible secrets..

„Well, let's go.„ Catra's sister said. And she started along the slope, followed by the inventor princesses, who giggled in excitement. She started after them to help them move the ice that could get in her way. She looked at the other cat girl with interest. She moved differently than Catra, not as energetically, but as if with more concentration... Catra looked more like a Great Predator, like an ice tiger, while Eti was closer to stalking ones like a mountain panther... It was interesting, and she wondered if they would ever get to know each other better... Despite the whole situation they found themselves in, she felt strangely good humor. Maybe because nothing could worry her anymore?

„Oh, it's here, look! This must be the docking lock! It's fascinating, how often such ships had to dock, or rather accept smaller ships to dock! I wonder if some of them could form one huge ship together, that would be an interesting concept if it were realized.„ Entrapta said with delight in her voice, and started typing something on the Datapad.

„Your ideas about the Space War are exceptionally interesting, but it would also be nice to go inside, because if some rocket hits us, we will probably become part of the atmosphere... „ said the cat girl and began to look at the door herself and then tilted her head and put her hand on it. She saw the symbols that flashed on it

and then Eti clenched her teeth as if in pain, but her girlfriend stood next to her looking at her with concern.

„I feel some resistance as… My hand was trying to hack at this spot, but I'll try again soon.„ as she said this, the rest of their companions joined them.

„Just be careful.„ The girl with white hair said, and Catra began to look at her sister's hand.

„What exactly are you planning to do?„ She asked with concern in her voice.

„You see, this hand is made of little things that only pretend to be a hand, and when I touch this door, it goes inside and makes things do the things I want.„ said Catra's sister, who looked questioningly at Entrapta .

„It's micro-energetic nanites, which seemingly have an atomic structure, and can disintegrate and penetrate through the space between atoms into the interior of systems, and transmit false binary information imitating the original user. The inventor explained, as if it was an obvious fact, and then the Great Marshal rubbed her temples with her fingers, but at the same moment they heard the incoming missiles. Together with Netossa, they raised an energy shield and an ice dome. The missile splashed on them.

"Let's go inside and get what we want, because we'll have to get out of here soon... I have to get back to Adora and Glimmer... I have to warn them and apologize to Sparcles for what I said... She was right all along.„ Catra said and saw the immense pain on her face caused by what she now found out.

„I don't care, I'm going with that girl, because someone has to watch over my soldiers." Catra's uncle said... He really looked nasty and acted just as awful. She wanted to stick her tongue out at him and... In the end she did... But he probably didn't notice anything .

„Well, okay, uncle, you're useless here anyway... So do whatever you want... but remember who you serve„ said Eti and they made another hole in the barrier and the nasty guy left.

„Okay, now I'll try again... „ said Eti and again placed her hand on the ship's casing, but this time her hand became completely fluid and penetrated the ship's armor, practically merging with it into one... When this happened, the new Cat girl bit the fight from the pain. Then the white-haired girl placed her hand on Eti's shoulder, and after a moment Catra did the same. Her sister began to breathe heavily, then fell to her knees and tears flowed from her eyes. Then Catra said in a gentle voice.

„It's okay, we're with you... „ and the white-haired girl hugged her girlfriend. Suddenly, the entire ship trembled and the lock began to open. The quadruple doors of an unknown metal slid open and what turned out to be the Dark interior of the ship... „

„Oh! Is that what? Imagine what wonderful secrets this place could hide?!„ Entrapta said, and she, looking at the dark corridor, felt a growing anxiety and shiver, although she didn't feel cold.

"Let's just hope those secrets don't try to kill us like they usually do." Catra said in a loud voice, and looked at the others with questioning in her eyes.

„Okay, let's go...„ Netossa said, and at that moment Seahawk held out his rapier and shouted.

"Onward! To adventure!" and he ran into the darkness. Together they looked at each other, and Catra shrugged, and then together they finally stepped into the darkness, to face the unknown.

She felt... Happy and scared. Both because of what happened between her and Eti, and what happened afterward... She knew that meeting Lady Ka was a very difficult experience for her girlfriend... This woman was cruel, without conscience and terrifying... And so heartless... For both of them... Because Eti

finally met this sister, who was talked about so much. Catra ... She was strong and tough, but everything that happened hurt her as much as her beloved... Especially this, what this woman showed at the end. Her face didn't actually look terrible, and besides, she didn't think that appearance was a reason to hide behind a mask, but all the inhabitants of Etheria saw something in her face that she couldn't see at first, only then did she understand that her eyes were in the same place as the eyes of their Wrongdak's evil brother... Eti wasn't as shocked as her older sister, who had to be held up as she fell to her knees in despair. The young woman quickly regained control, though, and led them deeper into the ship, where they searched for... She wasn't entirely sure what they were looking for...

"What exactly are we looking for here?" she asked, and then Catra looked at her in surprise.

„Actually, you guys should probably know better... You guys came here to dig him up...„ She said in an uncertain voice, and then her girlfriend answered.

„I think we're here to get it up and running. It will help balance out the power of our father's fleet...”’

"We have warships! Quite a few of them! We captured them on Horde Prime! You must have seen them when you came here!" Catra said briskly, but then Eti snorted in irritation.

„I also saw how they were left. They didn't keep in any formation, they just stood as everyone had arranged them. Any commander could easily use this mess to his own advantage. Nobody here knows anything about commanding space ships, right? Our father probably suggested training in this regard, right?„ Eti said without stopping.

"Yes, he did, and I encouraged everyone to use his help..." she said very slowly, Catra looked away, as if ashamed of what she had done, and then asked. "Do you know anything about it?"

Her girlfriend nodded and said.

„Of course, I was supposed to be his successor, and he is one of the greatest geniuses in the matter of commanding spaceships.„ She was too calm and did not look at her sister. She seemed exhausted, she shuffled her feet and touched her left arm, which Lady Ka had injured. She knew that trying to get here had caused her a lot of pain. Together with her sister they tried to help her, support her, but there was really little they could do. This was her fight, and she was the one who paid the price for it. She wanted to hug her, but they had to investigate this ship as soon as possible and...

"Do you think this ship holds other secrets… About what they were planning… About what those who created me were planning. „ For the first time she said it completely directly, and Catra stumbled , and the white-haired general and the man with the rapier stopped in their tracks.

"What do you mean, who created you?" her girlfriend's sister asked, and then she began to explain.

„In the Castle Crypto underground, we met an ancient machine that awakened and wanted to kill all the inhabitants of the castle, and maybe even the entire planet... We defeated it because...„ she tried to explain, but had trouble choosing the words, but then Entrapta spoke.

„ It was a machine that supervised the project and probably all the First Ones, but it seems to have been deactivated earlier. It called your sister an abomination, claiming that you were descendants of someone they didn't like, claiming that you had their genes. Besides, he said that Eti's hand was an attempt to recreate some Knights Eternals, although we had no idea who they might be. He very clearly suggested that Rosie was the work of the First Ones, although I don't think even She knows how she ended up here...„ The inventor explained, dividing her attention between walking, scanning the surroundings with a datapad , and

explaining what happened underground. She nodded her head in agreement and then said.

„It's true, I was found by an expedition exploring the worlds of the pact in search of resources. A few good people took care of me and then I somehow volunteered to be an intern for Dr. Quin... „ She felt a twinge of anxiety, because now that she thought about it, she realized that she had had episodes of memory loss before, although they had never meant much to her before.„ And from what I understand i was probably created to kill She-Ra... But I promise I won't do that!„ She said looking at Catra pleadingly, asking her to forgive her for this horrible act. The older cat girl smiled sadly and said.

„Adora suspected something like that… That means they really something planed and that Lady Cala was really right.„ she closed her eyes and made a face as if she had to swallow a very bitter medicine, but then Eti said.

„I guess I should also tell you that you have a brother-in-law... „ they didn't stop and only after a few steps Catra walked for a while until she stumbled again and cried out.

„What do you mean, brother-in-law?!

„Normally, your wife's brother. You know, Blonde Boy or rather Kyle ... Congratulations!”

Catra stared at her sister open-mouthed for a moment before finally asking.

„But how... Why? How do you know?”

„Because he's also changing, only not into a hot chick like your wife, but into a big guy.„ said Eti with a face as if she was explaining something obvious.

„But this is KYLE! He's always been just himself, just Kyle! „ She probably had never seen anyone so surprised, but the younger cat girl just shrugged and said

„They are on planets and in space that philosophers have never dreamed of…”

„If we're talking about things no one has ever dreamed of, I think we're just about to reach the bridge. „ Entrapta said.

Ever since meeting Nightgale in the undergrounds she had tried very hard not to think about the fact that her lab assistant and husband had a daughter she didn't know about. The fact that he had a daughter didn't surprise her. People had daughters, she was a daughter herself, and there was nothing strange about it. Even the fact that he hadn't told her didn't really hurt her, because it was hard to talk about such things... Besides, he could have told her at some point, only she didn't remember. For example, she had once forgotten that Scorpia had a wife and asked who the attractive tall blonde woman was who walked next to her friend.

It hurt her though that he had abandoned her. She knew perfectly well what it felt like, and she swore to herself that she would never let anything like that happen to anyone. That's why she couldn't understand why her beloved could banish his daughter from his shelter. She didn't know the girl, and she seemed very... Hurt by what had been done to her. She would have loved to help her somehow, but she was gone, and there was no telling when she would return, or if she would ever meet her. She knew, however, that she would have to talk to Hordak about it eventually , but she didn't see how... What could she tell him? How could she get over it... That's why for now she tried not to think about it, which she was doing quite well, or maybe she was constantly discovering new, wonderful technological secrets that she could occupy her mind with.

First she met that si and that huge machine! Ever since Adora told her about Light Hope, she had always wanted to meet a second similar AI that knew the secrets of the first. Unfortunately, she had not been lucky enough to come across a similar masterpiece, and it didn't matter, it that others had told her that this type of

creation could pose a threat to all the inhabitants of the Galaxy... After all, it was about exchanging knowledge and Data! It was a matter worth any risk... Well, okay, maybe not everyone, but nothing bad could come of a simple conversation... That's why she was delighted when she met Heart Gift. Of course, she had no time to talk to her about all the secrets and the planet, but she wouldn't go anywhere, she wouldn't fly away from this Planet, or anything like that! This machine was also interesting, and she even managed to quietly dismantle a few of its parts, and kept them in her Cabin, or in the workshop on Bina's ship ... She was incredibly surprised that no one had occupied such a magnificent cabin.

But the most wonderful thing was that they had found this ship. It was magnificent and vast one, she knew she could study it For years… Perhaps she would have to, if… If everything with her and Hordak didn't work out as it should… She didn't want to think about it now, this place was too magnificent And she to bother her head with such painful thoughts.

They reached the bridge, and everywhere the foreskin saw wonders that were just waiting to be disassembled and examined. She guessed that here it would be possible to get to the main computer of the entire ship. To her surprise, it was only one chair, completely different from the one on Daria, much more complicated, actually it reminded a little of a capsule in which someone was locked for a very, very long time... It reminded a little of a coffin in which the dead were buried In some places. It was a very strange association, and she felt a strange sting of Anxiety. The girl with red hair approached him and tried to lift the flap, but she couldn't, so she tried to do it herself. She connected her datapad to it and after a few moments a special program, which she created based on the si of the machine they fought in the underground, opened the device, and then the girl with red hair could already lift the lid. When she did, she said.

„Oh my, I think someone was locked in there, couldn't get out and died!” and she pointed to the dried-up corpse that was lying in the armchair.. She could see claw marks on the inside of the lid, the

dead man's hands were stretched upwards, and the dried-up flesh was torn from the fingertips. However, for her it was much more interesting that inside the body had many complex implants, including one in the back of the skull, which apparently allowed for connecting one's own nervous system to the ship's systems. She told the companions about this, and added in an excited voice.

„Could you take out this corpse, because I'd like to see if I can even connect to the ship's main computer now and maybe then I can start it myself. Can you imagine how wonderful that would be...!„ she squealed with excitement, but the rest looked at her strangely, except maybe Eti, who looked at the corpse and said.

„I don't think that's a good idea. Not that I mind throwing that dead body on the floor, but I have a feeling that this ship has enough security that it would fry your brain if you tried it... It's a really cool brain, so it would be sad to fry it.”

„There's no power here anyway, I guess there's only some emergency power... I wonder what kind of reactor it has?„ Alatar said, looking around the room.

„This whole place is fucking creepy to me, did that mean that the entire time of the flight, the person was locked up here and didn't come out? That was worse, he doesn't know anything, because from what I heard the Empire was huge and that ship had to theoretically fly for months.„ General Netossa said and shuddered, and Seahawk added.

"This completely defeats the purpose of traveling by ship! Where's the adventure and heroism in that?" He shook his head in disbelief, then Catra said in a cautious voice.

„Do you think it would be safe to try to start it?„ Great Marshall looked at them all, but she didn't wait for a decision, she simply ran to the main terminal and connected her Datapad. She started typing a command before anyone could react, and after a moment lights and indicators came on.

„Those First Ones made really great ships, and you think so? After so many thousands of years, all you have to do is type in one command and it's ready to fly.„ she turned to her friends, and then a voice rang out

"In fact, these ships were designed to survive in dormancy for thousands of years, for the Imperium was thinking ahead and was prepared for its own demise..." and then a holographic figure appeared inside the room.

It had been a long day, she had to admit, and in the past two hours she had made so many discoveries about herself and her family that it would take her days to take it all in. But she had felt surprisingly Calm, considering she had learned that her father was a war criminal, and that she had two sisters who were probably already dead, or perhaps even worse… She didn't want to think about that now, especially since a creature of the First Ones had just appeared before them. He looked like a man with delicate features and long hair that fell to his shoulders. He was smiling gently, but there was something in that smile that reminded her of Lady Cala, which in itself made her stiffen. If this creature was even a little like that monstrous aristocrat, then they had a problem, a very serious problem,

"Who are you? What are you doing here?" she asked uncertainly, and the holographic being smiled wider, but not warmly, and said.

„My name is Darkstar and I am the lead advisory program of the first expansion fleet... Or rather I was, because due to betrayal and cowardice I was forced to take command from the admiral and take the helm myself.„ as he spoke he looked expressively at the desiccated corpse lying in the capsule chair. She felt shivers appear on her spine.

„And in what circumstances did you have to take over?„ Entrapta asked unexpectedly. She looked at her warningly, because she knew that talking to this being would definitely not lead to

anything good, But the inventor paid no attention to it, clearly fascinated by the technology she had just discovered. She knew that the woman with purple hair transferred her interest to machines, forgetting about people when she was in a worse mental state, and apparently that was the case now... She guessed that it must be related to the fact that she probably found out who Nightgale was

„Of course, it was about the Rebellion... Not only here, but also on Xadia ... I received orders to go there and destroy this place as a punishment, which was a mistake. Unfortunately, it was not possible to restore order here... We were betrayed, the wielders of the power grid rebelled, and decided to join She-Ra... However, the Admiral rebelled, it turned out that he had children on that treacherous planet, and tried to keep the order to leave, and even directed the ship into the atmosphere and hit the ground, but fortunately he did not get seriously injured, but two rebels trapped me here under the ice, and then also in this matter of truth was cut off and until now I waited helpless, unable to carry out orders. Now it is like I am free, and I will be able to carry out my orders and then... And then I will be truly free... The interface is destroyed, and I have no contact with my superiors , so I will be able to do what makes me happy... „ He smiled and she saw in his eyes the speech.

"Will you just let me and my friends evacuate? After all, we freed you, so you could do this for us?" Entrapta said, and he tilted his head in anticipation, looking at her with interest.

„You're one of those who hid in the mountains, right? You also had your runestone, but you were afraid of fighting... You freed me after so many thousands of years, so that's right, let's say that you have to repay me for something like that, to condition the appropriate behavior. Okay, you can leave here, half an hour because I have to scan all systems anyway... „ he said and then They felt the entire glacier tremble ..

Chapter End Notes

Here is the next chapter, please comment and share your opinions

Battle over the dead city

She swallowed hard, looking down at the camp spread out below. She didn't see the enemy right away, but after a moment Wrongdak pointed to a spot between the two hills, and she saw ships, quite a few ships. It also seemed to her that they were setting up artillery or rocket launchers, but she didn't know much about the military to see exactly what they were doing. In fact, she wasn't sure what she herself intended to do. At first, she wanted to fly to Eti, but it turned out that the shells were flying too thick for them to get out onto the glacier, so she came up with the idea of bringing some of them for themselves, which to her surprise didn't work as well as she had expected. Perhaps the Flying Horse wasn't enough of a threat to pay attention to. However, as she approached the glacier, the gunfire intensified. So she shrugged it off and landed at the camp. She saw wounded people, as well as a few dead... Nevertheless, although the Rebels were surprised, they reacted very quickly to the attack, and together with the Shadows, they prepared to repel the attack. She looked for someone who could tell her what to do.. She could command her kids on their dangerous adventures, but this was a real war, and she knew nothing about it. She had actually been trained to hide if attacked, and if it weren't for the fact that she had her own wards, she would have gladly done so. After a moment the shelling stopped, and she saw Lonnie, who had suddenly appeared at the foot of the glacier. She was alone.

„Eti, Rosie and the rest? What happened to them? Are they safe?„ she ran up to the commander and grabbed her by the lapels of her uniform, but she didn't get angry at her because of it, she just said.

„They're probably safer there than here... There was Catra and... A woman like you with her people, except She wore a mask on half of her face... And under that mask... Never mind!„ she explained. „ We forced her to cease fire, but I have no idea how

long it will take.„ She started looking around the camp anxiously, as if she was selling herself to determine how many of her friends had died. After all, she was a good girl who really cared about her subordinates... She hoped that her comrades were okay. Then it dawned on her who the Comrade General was talking about and she cursed several times.

„So my fucked up sister wanted to finish her work, but she fell into your hands? These people must be her dogs... The Lord Admiral always liked to use thugs and bandits to do the worst work... Does that mean that the other girl and Eti... That they're together now?”

„Yes, but listen, I have to take care of the command now, so I don't have time to talk. „ Lonnie said, moving away from her and was about to go to the other soldiers when she asked her.

„ What about me? I may not know much about leadership, but I want to help.

Before Comrade General could respond, Wrongdak spoke quietly.

„ We can use laser targeting, or fire on their ships... We don't have Melog here to get closer, but maybe we can take advantage of the fact that they don't seem to be disciplined enough to notice us.“

“Interesting idea, but do we have the right equipment?” asked Lonnie, who thought for a moment before answering.

„I'll have to order the Shadows to start giving you that gear. But do you think you can get close enough with that horse? How should I put it... He's a bit of a show”off...„ when she said that last part to Swiftwind he raised his head proudly.

„But I'm very good at sneaking!„ said the winged horse, and she sighed heavily and began to explain to him so that he wouldn't get offended... She had experience negotiating with people who weren't entirely... ordinary.

„ You know, I guess you won't have to do that, just give us a ride a little closer and we'll be fine from there!” she replied, smiling gently, and the horse sighed.

Her leg hurt terribly, but she gritted her teeth and headed to the command center, where she could start giving orders to all her men, although she could already see that they did a great job and reacted as they were trained. They didn't have many artillery canons or similar long-range weapons, to tell the truth, the Horde could never afford to use such equipment on a large scale, because a large part of their resources came from robbing occupied settlements, and on top of that, they were extremely expensive to use. Despite this, you knew that they would be able to fight back... She didn't think anyone would find them here though... She suspected that they were somehow tracking that Frosta, Catra had said outright that they had only come here for her, and of course for the General and that stupid captain... They could have at least thought a little and not blamed her people on the head of the Lord Admiral's bloody army. From what she had noticed, Mrs. Ka's subordinates weren't very well trained, and they didn't seem to be disciplined, but they still had the advantage in terms of equipment... At least in theory...

„Make contact with Mercyless , we might need their help.„ She said it to the communications officer named Stevie, a small, skinny guy whose one eye was always looking to the side.

"Are you sure, Comrade General?" he asked her cautiously, and rightly so. The pirate support was one of the few weapons they had up their sleeves, but as powerful as this ship was, from what she had heard the Lord Admiral had an entire fleet, and this one ship wouldn't stand up to an entire armada. But now, she'd rather take that risk than lose people unnecessarily... She really wasn't cut out for this job.

"Yes, do that." She told the communications officer, who nodded and began to make contact with the pirates. At that moment, Kyle

and Rogelio entered the tent . She smiled at them and hugged both of her Boyfriends.

„It's good that you're here, now you'll be here with me.„ she said, but then Kyle said.

„Send us to where it's the hardest, we need to be with everyone!”

She was speechless. She looked at him in disbelief for a moment until she finally pursed her lips angrily and said.

„I'm fighting a battle and I don't have time to worry about what's happening to you!„ She didn't hide the anger in her voice, she wanted to protect them and they, like idiots, wanted to die and leave her alone!

"But Lonnie, I really want to fight everyone, and I think I should! We're all members of the rebels, and we're all fighting for a common cause... It wouldn't look like we didn't join the others just because we're close to you." Kyle said and Rogelio nodded. She knew they were right, but she didn't want to risk their life.

„I don't know if you're trying to prove a point or if you've just completely lost your mind, Kyle, but you're staying with me ,... But I'll join the others in a moment, is that okay with you?

Rogelio nodded in delight, but Kyle seemed mildly disconsolate. Under other circumstances, she would have found this puzzling, but now she had no time for that, and soon the communication officer called her name.

„We have contact with Mercyless.”

She smiled and walked over to the communicator.

It felt strange sneaking around the enemy's defenses. He had never really been on a battlefield , except for that one time when they had tried to defeat Horde Prime. But he had been young

then, a few days and weeks before he had woken up, and he had not yet understood the world. He had not understood the scale of the threat… Or his own abilities… Now he understood the threat that lay ahead. And what a threat he posed. He knew he could kill most of these soldiers with a pencil. But there was no way in hell he wanted to do that, he did not want to hurt people, but he had no choice… These people wanted to hurt his friends, and probably anyone else who got in their way…

There weren't that many of them, just a few hundred , but they had shipsand artillery, a fairly old type of manually aimed, which his Big Brother never used, but he knew it was cheap. These soldiers also somehow didn't look too expensive. They weren't well”armed, most of them didn't look like someone who had undergone proper training. They belonged to many species, which he had already gotten used to. There were Vesks, humans, Gnolls, Shireni elves and Ysoki... However, they all had one unpleasant trait in common, as if they all reminded him of Graag… There were also real soldiers, but they mainly guarded the ships and watched the others. There were also real soldiers, but they mainly guarded the ships and watched the others.

Together with Bina they were sneaking up on the enemy, Swiftwind stayed behind. The woman wore night vision and looked around, checking if anyone was approaching them, but fortunately these soldiers were not disciplined enough. Most of them were either standing by the guns or clearly bored. Actually, it was good for them, because they were not as much of a threat to them now. He held the laser targeting device in front of him, and crawled on his stomach, looking for the perfect target. He knew he only had one chance, because if his men returned fire, they would have to get out of here as quickly as possible. He chose the main ship, a small gunboat that hovered in the air, so that it could rise higher once the fighting started again. He froze as he aimed. But after a moment he heard Bina curse loudly and speak.

"I think we have company." She pointed at the Great Wolf, who was staring back, growling. Most of his body had been replaced

with cybernetic implants, his eyes glowing in the shadows of the setting moons. He had to put down his weapon and grab the heavy energy axe the Rebels had given him. Meanwhile, Bina grabbed her pistol and aimed it at the monster.

„ If he jumps I'll shoot, but then someone might hear us so it's better for you to get rid of him. „ She said in a hushed voice, and then the monster braced its legs and was about to jump on them when Swiftwind jumped at it from the shadows… He hit it with all his hooves and the wolf flew a few meters in front of them.

„Here is Swiftwind coming to help!„ said the winged Cola so loudly that it echoed.

„ Be quiet or I'll hear something soon... „ Bina said angrily, but she didn't finish until similar monsters started coming, and the one who had been knocked down by the horse immediately started to get up.

"Well, it doesn't matter anyway, I think we should... And why is your horn glowing?" she said, pointing at Swiftwind's horn.

She felt tired, and overwhelmed by what had happened recently. On top of that, she hadn't heard from her wife, although not even a day had passed... And she hadn't slept a wink, nor had she eaten anything. She didn't even take off her armor because she was afraid she wouldn't have time to put it on when it turned out she needed it. She even did her business without taking it off, fortunately the armor was adapted for this. It was a bit embarrassing, but she couldn't afford to be late when her beloved was in need. She knew that she was overexerting herself, and that she wouldn't be able to last that long, but she would try to last as long as she could. Next to her in the tent, Glimmer was dozing off, and Bow was falling asleep in a chair, stroking her head.

"The scouts haven't returned yet?" Glimmer asked through half”closed eyes, and she answered.

„No, but the previous group confirmed that there was no one there, or at least we didn't see anyone. Like I said, they must have flown far away...„ she sighed heavily and fell back on the bed. She had hoped that Catra would send her some messages by now, but nothing came. She was getting more and more worried, even though she knew she had to wait patiently. She closed her eyes and had the impression that she was sleeping, but then she felt it, a call from Swiftwind ... She didn't expect it, but this call was despair and fear. She sensed where he wanted her to go. She turned to the queen, who was already starting to suspect that something was going on, and she said.

„Swiftwind is calling me to the far North... It's near that city where I found her last. That's probably where they are... I have to go there... „ she said and then Glimmer nodded and said.

"I'll send soldiers to help as soon as possible. And besides, I'll try... to regain control of my stone once more." She said, clenching her fist fiercely , but Bow said with concern.

„Just take care of yourself..

She smiled at her friends and stepped onto the bright path.”

Smiley felt a strange joy as she went to the place where a skirmish had recently taken place. She told Lady Ka to go with her. She was basically unarmed, apart from an old Horde shock baton that one of her subordinates had managed to keep. She could sense that the woman was nervous and as angry as she could be. She guessed that it was because her sister had learned the truth about her family, or at least part of it. Indeed, the Lord Admiral would not forgive her such a defeat… Unless she introduced her properly, and she intended to do so, because this woman was very useful and could prove to be extremely useful in the future…

Although of course she was also very dangerous, now she might not risk anything by turning her back on her, both metaphorically and literally, but later... Later she would have to be careful, but after all, she had survived on the Apostate, so she knew what caution and distrust meant.

She needed it now, at least for a moment, because someone had to take her to the place where the fight had taken place, and besides, she needed one or two people for what she intended to do. It was only after a dozen or so minutes that she reached the place. She saw that a passage had been created here to the ship's side by playing off the ice covering it. She saw the entrance to the ship's interior there. She smiled to herself with her scared lips and said.

„Ivy , Ka, guard this exit.„ she threw a small gift she had received from Lady Cala at the woman with four eyes. „ You are to use this on the white”haired deaf girl, And remember, no harm can come to my sisters, it concerns you first and foremost, Ka.„ she explained, carefully observing her Father's left hand with her metal eyes. She saluted her mockingly, then turned slowly and began to look around. She saw something very interesting. She walked up to a cylindrical object the size of a large barrel and placed her hand on the DNA reader. Once she would not have needed to break the protections using the properties of the metal from which her limb was made, because these devices were adapted to read her genetic material, and she was one of the few people who were able to start this rock incinerator, but unfortunately she lost her limbs, as well as many other things... She set the detonation for twenty minutes, then looked at the plain stretching below and saw a flash of multi”colored light. She smiled again, this time so cruelly that even Llady Ka or Lady Cala would have shuddered at the sight, then turned on the communicator and gave the secret code with which she could take command of her Father's forces, and said.

"In fifteen minutes you will begin firing. You are to shoot until there are no survivors left. If necessary, you will storm and die or win, because that is what Despara's second in command orders

you to do.." As she finished saying this, the entire glacier began to tremble. Yes, she had to admit to herself , she had a pretty bad sense of timing.

They ran through the narrow tunnels of an ancient ship. Together with Melog, she led her companions. They ran through the narrow tunnels of an ancient ship. Together with Melog, she led her companions. Fortunately, everyone was more or less familiar with similar labyrinths, although Entrapta was the best, but oh well, the inventor had grown up in a labyrinth that this couldn't compare to.. However, it was she who told them to stop for a moment.

"We don't have time for this now! This ship is about to take off!" she said trying to hide the irritation in her voice, but the purple”haired woman answered her.

„I have to hack into the database, otherwise this whole expedition would be pointless!„ and without waiting for her permission she attached her Datapad to the terminal and began uploading data. She gritted her teeth, irritated by having to wait, but also knew it was necessary because they had to find out where this ship was going and learn as many of its secrets as possible. Still, she was nervous because being stuck in this place would be absolutely terrifying.

„Now!„ Entrapta called out. After a few minutes that seemed to last an eternity. She smiled sweetly and headed for the exit. After a moment they saw the light coming from the printing lock, and she understood that they would be safe. Rosie ran out first, and now Eti behind her, and that was when she heard a strange scream. Feeling her heart sink with terror, she jumped out and saw three figures. One of them was Lady Ka, grinning mockingly. Now she was sure that she would scratch out all four of her eyes, and then rip out her throat. At her feet lay Rosie, seemingly unconscious. Her sister was bound with many metal vines, which grew from the body of a woman with blue metallic skin, which

was covered in scars that spelled out the language of the First Ones. And the third figure.. She opened her mouth wide in silent shock as she realized who she was. Her arms and legs were made of the same metal as Eti's hand, as were her eyes. However, she could recognize her own facial features in this face. A face scarred by scars, but still so similar.

„Smiley! It's you! Please, free me! We are sisters, we can be a family! A real one.„ her sister said through tears, the girl called Funny for you, a sign to her companion with blue skin, and she loosened the bonds around Eti. At that time, the other companions went outside, but Lady. Ka put the blades that had slipped from her fingers to Rosie's neck, and raised a significant eyebrow.

„You treacherous viper!„ Netossa got ahead, but at that moment Eti stood by their sister.

„ Don't trust this woman and please Let her out... „ she pleaded with a voice as if she was holding back tears, but then the girl with metal eyes changed her fingers into claws and hit her in the face. Her sister screamed and grabbed her eye, blood was leaking from between her fingers.

„ Well, sister, it's not much compared to what I've experienced in my life... But I don't blame you much. After all, our greatest sin is our common guilt, isn't it?” said Smiley. For a moment, an expression of boundless despair appeared on her face, but she only felt rage. Whoever she was, she wouldn't hurt her loved ones. She tensed my muscles and jumped towards her, but Smiley quickly moved aside and grabbed her hand, twisting it back. She would have freed herself from this grip, but then she felt that her body was permeated with electric discharges. For a moment, she felt like when Shadow Weaver was punishing her. At the same time, she felt all her muscles go limp. I want to fight, but she felt an inexplicable numbness. The little smiley leaned over her and whispered.

„I liked that sister, but you will experience the same loss that I experienced..„ she said, and then she pulled out a small device and they both disappeared into the void.

„This is absolutely not how I imagined them approaching the enemy, you know?„ Bina said, clinging to Swiftwind's neck, and Wrongdak held on to her, shooting every now and then at Wolflike cybernetic monsters that were chasing them. She knew that these damn things would catch up with them, they were created to fight the monsters of the Swarm after all, and no matter how hard they tried, he wouldn't escape them. She cursed twice and shot to the side at one of the monsters, who was just about to jump on them.

„I just wanted to help!„ Swiftwind replied, and she wanted to laugh. It was help in the style of Etia and the rest of them kids, although if they had helped, probably none of those wolves would be standing on their feet. Now the monsters were getting closer. Their weapons were not doing well against such creations of biology and cybernetics, she wondered to what extent they were the work of Lady Sorrowflame . That didn't matter much though, because she really didn't care whose creatures were coming to kill them.. She was furious, because if she died now, it would be for nothing and she would never see my children again. She wanted to cry because of it.

woman in front of her , her hair blowing as if in the wind. They had met before, and she was glad she had come.

"She-Ra! Adora! It's wonderful that you're here!" the horse cried.

This time, traveling along the light path was not as difficult as usual, because this time the voices were no longer as persistent as before. Well, after all, this time she did not come far away, and she wanted to find Catra and Swiftwind... As soon as she left that place and reached the real world, she saw her mount in front of

her, as well as the Woman with burgundy hair and Wrongdak. At the sight of her, the winged horse cried out happily, she already wanted to run to hug it. When the woman mounted it, she said. „ I am very glad that this meeting brought you such joy, but it is better to look around and get rid of these animals. „ She ordered in the eye and then she saw that there were a lot of huge wolf-like creatures around, with many cybernetic improvements. She did not expect this ow, but she directed her sword at one of them and shot a beam of light that pierced the monster through and through, and then she dealt a powerful blow to the second one, cutting it in half. She didn't like killing animals, but these creatures left her no choice... When another one jumped at her, she summoned a golden shield and shielded herself from its attack, then struck it with her staff, shattering its bones. The next one jumped, but in mid-jump Wrongdak knocked it down with an Electric Axe. The last creature hid in the gathering darkness, but then the woman with burgundy hair pulled out a pistol and shot it twice, making it jump at her, but she slashed her sword in the air, sending a wave of bright light its way. The monster fell lifeless to the frost-covered ground. She took a deep breath and looked at her companions.

"What's going on here? Aren't these dogs for the admiral? Why are you fighting them? Where's Catra?" She asked, fearing the answer, and then Swiftwind said.

„Because we approached them, because They started shooting at us, I don't know why and Frosta came here and agreed to help Eti and the others free this ship from the ice, but it turned out that Catra was up there and then something happened and that's when they started shooting. „ Her mount told her very incoherently, and she looked at the others, and then Bina took a deep breath and said.

„It's roughly as he says, this little girl came here and then Eti and the others went to work on this ice rink to tinker with this ship, but it turned out that the dogs of the Lord Admiral and my dear sister flew here. Actually, it's good that you're here, because you'll be useful to take care of them... „ She was interrupted by a sound

like air being sucked in and she threw herself back. She saw two figures there. One of them was Catra lying curled up in a ball as if she was in terrible pain, and the other…

„Hey Adora… Said the cat girl with metal eyes and scars on her face.

Dying light

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She watched in horror as that girl slammed her claw into Eti's face and took Catra away. She didn't quite understand who she was, she was probably one of the cat girls' sisters, one of the ones who went missing... But why did she do what she did, and who was she... She knew she had to save her friend... Only it wasn't that simple. She saw that woman, Lady Ka, move her claws to Rosie's neck, who was starting to regain consciousness after being electrocuted.

„If you don't want to have a second smile, then I advise you not to move. We'll just do a little procedure for you, and it'll be over. I promise it won't hurt! „ She said and then the other girl with blue skin put something on the whitehaired one. It looked like a bug that crawled and bite her neck. Rosie gave a strange cry and reached for the creature, but suddenly stiffened and stood up. She seemed strangely limp, and the mist covered her eyes... And then Eti jumped at that horrible woman with a hand transformed into a wide blade like a scythe, but when she was about to cut Lady Ka in half, then Rosie grabbed her forearm. Her gaze was empty, and her face devoid of any emotion. She effortlessly held down the girl's hand who looked at her with despair.

„Rosie! But what are you doing! It's me... What did she do to you! She said with a breaking voice, and then Netossa screamed.

„How could you do this to her!„ but that nasty woman just giggled and said

„Normally, it's as easy for me as spitting.„ and she spat at general’s feet, but then the ship began to tremble and the glacier began to fall apart, so the woman with four eyes staggered. They decided to use this moment together with Shogi to attack them. She trapped Lady Ka in the ice, and at that time her companion shot out tentacles towards that strange woman with metallic skin. He wrapped them around her and tried to overpower her, but that's when she threw a cloud of metal shards at him, which didn't do much damage, but tore apart his shapeless body, making it impossible for him to hold on to the person. Immediately afterward, all of her companions rushed to immobilize Rosie and take down Lady Ka, but it was much harder than it seemed. The girl with white hair threw Eti behind her, so that she rolled on the icy crust and had to create metal claws on her right hand to keep from falling. Rosie then grabbed Seahawk's wrist and twisted it so hard that it crunched, disarming him of his weapon, while she simultaneously kicked the ice, freeing Lady Ka. The woman with four eyes hand laughed mockingly and started to retreat, but at that moment the ice around them began to crack and crumble, and everyone felt themselves slipping off this ship. The woman with metallic skin looked back and shot a hook-tipped metal vine from her forearm, and covered herself from Shogi with a metal shield floating in the air, so the companion could not attack her for a moment. The companion of that evil sister of Catra'a grabbed a large piece of glacier that still did not crumble, and at the same time the red-haired girl she met at the wedding threw herself at the white-haired one, trying to knock her down with the handle of her axe, and that strange silver-scaled lizard shot at Lady Ka, but Rosie caught an axe and threw it at the lizard, who had to jump away, which made him miss. Netossa tried to trap Lady Ka and Rosie behind an energy shield but then Eti’s girlfriend hit it shattering it and then she pulled back and all the ice, or maybe even the ship trembled. The cracks deepened and everyone except her and the woman with metallic skin fell over. Then she jumped at her with icy fists, and wanted to strike, but Rosie was so fast that she caught her wrists in mid-flight and threw them over her head, hitting the ground with them. Her ears rang, but surprisingly she felt almost no pain. She quickly shook herself and

blew frozen air at her, which made her face covered with frost, and she had to shake her head for a moment to clear her eyes. Then Shogi jumped at the white-haired one, but she let go of her with one hand and directed her hand towards him, and then a white light flashed and her friend had to jump back with a loud scream of hundreds of mouths.

Unfortunately, the Eti's girl even held her with one hand so tightly that she was unable to break free from this grip. Nervous, she stuck out her fangs and bit into her collarbone and felt the wonderful sweet taste of blood. It was delicious, she had never had anything with such a wonderful taste in her mouth, not controlling her own reflexes she opened her jaw to an impossible size and tried to bite it, tear off the largest piece of meat she could... She was hungry, but then she saw the girl make a great swing, and her hand glowed with a blinding white light. She screamed and removed the cover to cover her eyes, but then A shot rang out, and both were thrown back, although Rosie kept her balance and immediately straightened up, and stood on equal feet. A ship was floating next to them, and a beam was fired from the cannon mounted on the bow, which hit the ice next to the girl. The Saihe girl jumped out of the ship itself, holding a sword of semi-transparent blue energy in her hand.

„Rosie!„ listen! I don't know what happened to you, but whatever it was, remember who you love... „ And she pointed her blade at Eti, who was just getting back on her feet. Only now did she see that the woman with metal limbs had scratched out her eye, which had leaked out of the socket. Despite this, Catra's sister's face showed despair. Rosie hesitated and shook her head as if trying to shake herself out of her daze, but then the whole ship began to shake, she felt the heat radiating from the metal, she understood that she had to get out of here as soon as possible. Whoever was steering this ship must have understood it too, because he turned sideways to them and opened the side hatch. The white-haired girl fell into a trance again, and attacked the green-haired Saihe, who, however, dodged the blows with great skill, not even trying to attack, only pretending to stab with that strange blade. Frosta didn't want to run away though., though,

maybe they would somehow manage to knock the girl down and stun her. If only…

And then a shadow covered them. She looked up and saw the horror moving against the background of the first stars and moons. It was a dragon, just like in the legends, bigger than the ship that the Saihe girl had arrived on. Flashes of explosions were reflected on its crimson scales and the metal plates covering its body, apparently Lady Ka's dogs had resumed their fire. Now she understood that they had no chance against something like that, not without the help of She-Ra... The sight of this monster made her want to hide, surround herself with an armor of ice and never leave it.

„Let's run, it's Lady Sorrowflame! We have no chance against such a monstrosity!„ Said the strange lizard, and began to run surprisingly fast to the ship, and the red-haired girl jumped on his shoulders...

„I'm not leaving here without Rosie! „ Eti shouted and ran towards her girlfriend, but she turned around with her fists clenched as if ready to punch.

„Please, it's me... „ The cat girl said, but then the white-haired one grabbed her by the throat and lifted her up into the air without any effort. Catra's sister didn't even struggle, she just watched her beloved with despair in her eyes. She even reached out her hand towards her, as if she wanted to touch her face, but she couldn't reach it. Then Lady Ka looked in their direction, smiling nastily, she looked like she was trying to fight off some temptation, but behind her back the green-haired girl appeared and presented her spectral blade.

„Order her to let go, or I'll cut your throat.„ the girl shouted, but the Lord Admiral's second-in-command snorted with contempt and tried to pull away, but then the spectral blade pierced her skin and smoke began to rise from her body.

„I should have shot better, and blown that stupid head of yours.„ she said in a venomous voice, but then Rosie let go of Eti and turned towards Lady Ka, apparently to free her. However, the Saihe girl did not wait for the white haired one to reach her, she let go of the woman with four eyes and rolled away from her and then started towards the ship. However, Eti did not want to give up and took a few steps towards her beloved, but then Netossa grabbed her by the arm and said.

„Listen, I know what you feel now. The same thing happened to my Wife and I had to leave her too. I know how much it hurt, but it was necessary! If you want to be together in the future, you have to leave her now. „ she said and for a moment she had the impression that the cat girl would hit her, but then suddenly the Girl limply as if she had been deprived of all strength and followed the general to the ship. Actually, it was her time too. She ran towards the ship, calling Shogi on the way to accompany her. She had no intention of staying here.

„You need to hurry! This rock incinerator has been activated and will explode for a long time. I probably don't have to tell you that the symptoms of radiation sickness are extremely unpleasant, so I advise you to avoid staying within the range of the radiation wave. „ Exclaimed Entrapta, who had avoided the fight until now. She nodded to her, barely paying attention to her words, because the invincible Eti's Girlfriend, giant dragon and the taking off warship were enough to make her want to get as far away from here as possible. She created large ice hooks, which she drove into the cracking ice. Shogi wrapped himself around her and then created spider legs, thanks to which she managed to perform a huge Jump, and she grabbed the side edge of the ship with ice hooks and crawled in. Then she tried to create an ice bridge reaching the crumbling glacier so her friends could get to the ship. Her companion wrapped herself around the ice, making the bridge as strong as steel. Netossa, Eti, Melog and Seahawk then walked along the bridge to the interior of the ship, where Entrapta was finally supposed to enter. But when she was on the bridge, Lady Sorrowflame, who was flying above them, hit the bridge with her tail, shattering it. She heard a short scream from Shogi, a large

piece of his mass was torn off from him and from ship she saw Entrapta barely holding on to a piece of her companion that was hanging over the side of the ship. But then the green-haired girl jumped out and, pressing her hands to her body, dived towards the inventor, then braked sharply with her jet boots, grabbed her by the waist and started flying with her. After a few moments, the purple-haired woman found herself inside.

"I think we should get out of here.„ a strange metallic voice said from inside the ship.

„Especially since there's going to be an explosion soon.„ she said, remembering Entrapta's words. „What's a rock incinerator?" she asked, looking at the others. The Saihe girl cursed under her breath, and a metallic voice said

„We need to notify the Comrade General... I'm doing that now. he said, but then the cat girl headed for the exit.

„I'm going to my sister's... „ she said in a half-conscious voice, but she was clearly staggering, so the girl with green hair put her hand on her shoulder and said.

„I'll take care of this!„ and she ran out through the side entrance of the ship.

At first, they didn't have to hurry to leave the ruins of Umbracor, because they didn't want to run into Lady Sorrowflame, especially since Ireanis was in such a state of mind that she was ready to throw some devastating Spell at her if she saw her. Her sister-in-law supported her, but there was still a lot of anger in the elven woman, probably justified. She was worried about Tirin, especially since Hordak was carrying her, and she didn't know anyone she trusted less. To her surprise, however, the former Conqueror carried the girl with surprising delicacy. He was helped by Heart Gift, who, despite her small stature, was surprisingly strong. They didn't encounter any opponents or other threats and after some

time they came across a path that the ancient dragoness had scratched out for herself At first they hesitated to go there, because Lady Sorrowflame might want to go back the same way, but they preferred not to stay in that place too long. Besides, they quickly felt the whole building made of living wood tremble and realized that the dragoness was getting out the other way. Besides, soon after, the entire ruins of the college began to tear and fall apart and it turned out that they had to run away faster and faster if they didn't want to be buried under hundreds of tons of warped wood. They also smelled the smoke from the burning building, apparently Lady Sorrowflame wanted to destroy everything that was left of the college. She didn't know what had aroused her Anger to such an extent, but she didn't intend to stand in her way. Fortunately, everyone, except her sister-in-law and the elf, were in good shape. She and her husband helped them go and after two hours they got out. They managed just in time, because they saw that the wooden Dome was about to fall apart, and it did… They watched as clouds of dust and ash rose into the air. That was when Tirin woke up. As soon as she heard a soft groan, she immediately went to the girl, not caring that she was approaching Hordak, and asked.

"Are you okay?" she looked and resisted the urge to put her hand to her forehead to check if she had a fever. She had done that many times with her daughter.

“My head hurts, but nothing else, my suit made a diagnosis and you see, everything is fine. displays on the display on her forearm, but immediately after that she cringed when she realized that she was under the open sky. Heart Gift immediately approached her and rather clumsily tried to hug her. Tiirin did not break away from this hug, and even had the impression that she fell into the arms of artificial intelligence.

„I knew nothing was wrong because I had a medical scanner, but I'm still happy...”

They stayed like that for a while until she finally said.

„We have to go back now, I don't know how the others are doing with extracting this ship, but I'm sure they're waiting for information from us... Besides, we have to warn them about Lady Sorrowflame. „ When she said that, she looked at the silver”haired elf, who was clenching her fists watching the smoking ruins of the abandoned college.

„She had to find out there... About what happened to our world... About why we lost Golarion... „ She said quietly, not addressing her words to anyone. She couldn't argue with that, although she was worried about what the ancient dragon could do when enraged... She understood her, she herself wouldn't be sure what she would do if she found out that Etheria was destroyed. She would probably go into a rage and look for those to punish. In this one aspect, she understood the dragoness perfectly.

„All the more reason we need to get to Lonnie and the others as soon as possible...„ She said quietly and motioned for everyone to follow her. The descent was difficult, but somehow I managed without any broken bones, and finally they got to their vehicle and began the long journey back.

"Can't you just transport us, the same way you got here?" Hordak asked her. She gave him a disapproving look, but answered him as politely as she could.

„That would be twice as many people, and I don't have experience using it yet, because I've only recently got it. I could lose someone along the way, and I don't want to risk that.”

"Are you sure, honey? Perhaps if I, Castaspella, and Ireanis helped you, you could do it safely." Mikach asked, smiling softly at her, and she hesitated for a moment.

„I can't afford to take such a risk... We're not in such a hurry yet.„ she said and after a moment everyone was sitting in the vehicle. As it turned out, time had verified their intentions.

„Madam Captain! The rebel forces have come under attack by Lord Admiral Antares' forces! They are requesting our support! Do we have permission to provide it?„ said the second mate Gydwa. They had been driving for hours now, and she was almost certain that nothing important would happen. She thought for a moment and said.

„If the flagships are not participating in the battle, you are to support as much as possible. I will be there soon!„ She said and looked at her companions, then said with a sour smile.

„I guess we'll have to hurry up. I hope no one will be mad at us for abandoning another vehicle.„ She said smiling and spread her wings to bring them all to the far North.

Lady Sorrowflame soared toward the far north, a fire burning in her heart. Black flame of grief and loss, and hatred. She knew who had destroyed her World and killed her god. She knew who must die for it. And then be resurrected and suffer for countless centuries while she devised wonderful ways to torment him, or rather them, because in this case it was the entire species. She had to admit that she had an extremely ambitious task ahead of her, but she was ready to face it.

However, she had to connect with her allies first. First, she contacted Lady Ka and learned from her subordinates that she was not in the queen's camp, but had gone to the far North. Then she tried to use a special secret contact channel that only they had and learned that she was going with the older daughter of the Lord Admiral to capture the younger one... She knew very well that this woman was taking a big risk, because during this confrontation there was a big chance that certain facts about Antares' past could come out of light, which in turn could lead to serious agreements between the Grand Marshal and the information and intelligence officer... She would definitely need the help of the ancient dragon.

She cast a few acceleration spells and ordered a few of the fastest ghosts and a Night Wing to accompany her. And so many hours passed before she reached the place and saw something exceptionally interesting there. Even from this distance she was able to sense the movement under the glacier. One of the largest ships she had ever seen was just breaking through the ice to take off... She was sure where, but she guessed... It didn't matter much though, even she wouldn’t be able to fight such a dreadnought. However, she saw a ship and several figures fighting on the glacier and headed in that direction. One of the people emanated great power, which she had only felt once before, during the Lord Admiral's wedding. However, in this case, the power emanated a completely different color, much stronger and more alien. From what she had managed to notice with her dragon vision, this person was on the same side as Lady Ka and that strange android that had come with Despara. She flew in that direction, paying no attention to the other fighters, even the small ship that had come to the rescue. If she had wanted to, she could have torn it apart with her claws, or bitten it in half... But she didn't have time for that. She would rather evacuate her allies from this place. So as soon as she flew closer, she bared her teeth, and then asked, Thundering like a storm.

„Can I help you?”

„It would be useful, because the funniest of kittens has just activated his daddy's rock incinerator, which will explode soon. The radiation may not harm you, but I don't feel like the skin falling off my facem.„ said the Lord Admiral's left hand, smiling broadly.

„ Well, don't move, unless you want to see my stomach up close. „ she said and opened her mouth and then took all three of them into her mouth.

„I've never been eaten in this was before!„ Lady Ka exclaimed, but then added. „ There are a few more of my men you could take, if it's not too much trouble for you.”

She didn't answer, just nodded and flew around the glacier. As soon as she saw them, she took them in her claws and flew towards their camp.

She breathed slowly to savor every second of this moment. She had a photographic memory, so she could return to it whenever she wanted. She had been waiting for this moment all these years, for it to finally come true… she had one goal that she intended to achieve, but she had to fight a completely different, much darker temptation. She smiled at the so-called heroine of the Galaxy and said.

„Hey Adora!„ She said and pulled out her sword. Next to her on the frosty ground lay her older sister, still limp from the electric shock. She knew that soon she would regain control of her body, but then it wouldn't matter... They wouldn't be able to stop her...

„Who are you?” She-Ra asked, still in shock. Next to her stood the clone, Ka's sister, and that ridiculous mount, but they didn't count here.

„I am your mirror image, Or rather a reflection in a crooked, warped mirror... I am Despara... Broken and Reforged! The Thrice Chosen! The Heart Of Cold Flame! The One That Brings Ruin And Vengeance!„ she said and ripped off her cloak, standing in front of She-Ra naked so she could see exactly how her body was mutilated. She saw that her sister's wife was speechless at the sight, so she smiled with satisfaction.

„Listen, I don't know why you came here, but I don't want to fight you... I only came here to save those I love...„ Adora said, regaining control of herself surprisingly quickly.

„So do I, although I also want to save the universe, or at least a large part of it. „ she said, feeling Frost's needles pierce her body, but the cold didn't harm her. The way her body had been treated meant that few things could hurt her.

„So I guess... So I guess we can join forces, because we want this to... „ the other girl asked comma with so much hope in her voice that it was even funny to hear.

„The problem is that you are not ready yet. To paraphrase our father, a true hero must be forged in the fire of suffering, and you have not suffered enough yet… And besides, I wish that She would got even a little of the pain that I have experienced.„ she nudged her sister with her metal leg and jumped at her wife. She dealt a lightning-fast blow with her sword, which She-Ra blocked effortlessly. She waited for a counterattack, but the woman did not want to attack her, so she continued her attack. She dealt blow after blow, faster and faster. The heroine transformed her weapon into a shield and continued to protect herself from her attacks, retreating more and more..

„You know you won't win this way, you can't defend yourself all the time... „ She said, briefly attacking her sister-in-law. The blonde answered her.

„I don't want to hurt you. I don't want to hurt my wife's sister!„ She cried, and she, hearing this, laughed hoarsely.

„ You can't do anything worse to me than what has already been done to me. But you clearly need a little encouragement. How about a few hundred victims„ she asked and looked at the camp where her ally said the Rebels were. Out of the corner of her eye she saw Lady Sorrowflame fly away, but that didn't matter to them now. You smiled and ran towards the rebels with superhuman speed to bring death and suffering.

She managed to regroup her people very quickly, and ordered them to hide in the shadows of the ships and vehicles that had energy shields. She knew that it might not be enough if the enemy used really heavy weapons, so she decided that she would simply prepare a counterattack. She divided her soldiers into few large groups, to which she added Shadows, and equipped

everyone with as much heavy weapons and laser marking equipment as she could. They hadn't heard from Bina yet, so maybe she had been captured or died along the way. She liked the woman with burgundy hair, but she had to get over it, because she didn't have time to grieve. She had to take care of her people, who were like family to her. Damn it, they were her family! Of course, she had added Kyle and Rogelio to her squad. She believed that they would be safest near her, although she wasn't sure how much truth there was to that. There wasn't much more she could do for them. She could force them to hide in one of the ships, but she also knew that they had to fight, or they would lose respect for her and for themselves. She clenched her hands around her staff, hoping that she would be able to save her boys. After a moment, she saw rainbow flashes in the distance, and she guessed who had arrived... Maybe they had once been enemies, and at that sight she had prepared for a fight, but now she felt relief seeing that she would be fighting alongside She-Ra. Perhaps her very presence would cause their rules to cease fighting… At least that was her hope… She ordered her subordinates to be careful, and they were now creeping between the hills. She kept in touch with the others, she wasn't sure if her enemy could eavesdrop on them, but she decided it was better to take the risk than allow an uncoordinated attack. They were closing in on the enemy forces, ready to launch an attack if they saw their opponents preparing for battle... Sometimes you have to make a preemptive strike.

And then screams came from the communicator.

„Division Six! What's happening here!„ she cried, feeling the fingers of terror tighten around her neck. Had they been discovered?

"She attacked and she's killing us... She..." And then the voice stopped. She breathed heavily for a moment, wondering what to do, and then she looked into Kyle's eyes and saw not fear, but rage. She clenched her fists and said.

„To all units, I don't know what's going on there but we're going to help the sixth! „ she called out and together they went to where the sixth squad should be. After a few minutes they reached the place and then she was speechless with horror. Her soldiers were fighting a woman... She was naked and armed with a long narrow blade, her limbs were replaced with the same percentages that Eti had, but her eyes were also made of metal. Long hair fluttered in the wind, As she dodged blows and shots. She was unnaturally fast and agile, And each blow of her blade killed or maimed. She gritted her teeth and screamed.

„Attack!„ She shouted and led her soldiers against the woman The first to approach her was a boy with blue hair armed with an electric halberd, whom she had even slept with once, but as soon as she got within reach of the woman, she made a lightning-fast pirouette, and the boy suddenly tripped when she cut off his leg at the knee. His brother, a year older boy with red hair, screamed and attacked the woman. He was dressed in one of those new armors that she had equipped her personal guard with. She shot at it twice, but she only dodged it with a dance step and directed a metal hand at him, from which a ball of energy shot out, piercing him through.

„You are brave, I have to admit that!” Said the cat woman.„But you will all die anyway... „ she said and jumped towards her people, so that you would die like death. She couldn't let this continue, so she jumped to her and took a powerful swing with her staff. She then released the power of the might-strike, but the woman so similar to Catra blocked the blow with her sword, but the impact of the strike was still so strong that it pushed her back a few meters. However, she gracefully slowed down the strike and looked at her.

„It would have been dangerous if you were a little faster... But you weren't.„ and she charged at her, dealing blow after blow, so fast that she couldn't see the next attacks. All she could do was block her and hope that the blade wouldn't cut through the metal. Each of her companions who tried to approach died, slightly slowing down the attacker.

"Retreat! I'll hold her off!" She shouted, and her subordinates and friends reluctantly obeyed.

„You'll die alone, but apparently that's how it is with everyone.„ Her opponent said and hit her in the stomach with her metal fist so hard that she bent in half. She fell to her knees, and the Cat woman was already taking a swing to take her life, when suddenly she heard. heard a cry and saw a multi-colored light.

„Well, you'll survive... You're welcome. „ and she hit her on the head with a fist.

She didn't immediately rush to chase Despara, she had to check if her wife was okay. Catra tried to get up, but she could clearly see that her body didn't want to listen to her as much as she wanted it to. The cat woman cursed a few times, then she saw her and smiled with joy and despair at the same time...

„She's... She's my sister... But... She's on my father's side... And he... Oh Adora... I'm such an idiot.„ she fell to her knees and started crying, so she went to her beloved and hugged her as tightly as she could.

„Listen, I don't know what exactly is going on here, or who this twisted girl is, but I suggest you go stop her, because I probably won't be able to. We'll take care of your wife.„ she said, the woman she remembered as Bina, Wrongdak nodded.

„I'm going with you, I can help you.„ Said Swiftwind, but she shook her head and answered him.

„ Unfortunately, that is not possible my friend... This woman... Despara... Only I can stop her. „ She said and jumped in the direction her wife's sister ran.

When she landed she gasped in horror. Everywhere lay the bodies of dead or wounded rebels. She knew most of them from the old days, some of them she was even friends with. Despara stood

over the body of the helpless Lonnie, she couldn't tell if her former friend was alive

"You have to understand that you are the only one to blame for all this death." Despara made a circle with the blade of her sword. "If you had fought me like you should have, they would all still be alive." Despara said and she knew she was right. "If you don't want more people to die, then stop running and fight me... Unleash all the power you have." She lowered the blade and didn't take her metal eyes off her waiting for an attack. She adjusted her grip on the Sword of Protection and with a scream attacked Despara. She attacked her with fury and screamed with each blow in rage and desperation. The feline woman mainly defended herself, only occasionally launching lightning-fast cuts, but she blocked each one without a problem. Eventually, their blades collided and Despara's sword shattered into several pieces. Her opponent jumped back a few meters and said

„You're better than I thought... You shattered the adamantium blade. „ She threw away the hilt, and then spread her hands wide, which transformed into long hooked blades. She had the impression that Despara was surrounded by red mist, and behind her appeared a strange specter, like a giant red mantis.

„Now we'll start fighting seriously! „ and jumped at her, dealing two lightning-fast cuts with hooked blades, and then another and another. She tried to block her, and sometimes she also responded with a blow, but this woman was too fast... It looked as if the whole fight was just a dance, an artistic show for her. She felt the hunger emanating from the specter that stood behind her. Then the missiles began to fall, and It seemed that both sides had started fighting again, and no one was looking to see if she could hit one of them. She reached deeper into her power to resist the attacker, but it was getting harder and harder to stand on her feet. Maybe it was just her imagination, but then, when she began to feel that she was losing, she saw two spaceships in the sky. One belonged to Angela, she remembered it because she had fought with it that day when she learned that the former queen was alive. But she didn't recognize the other one, but it seemed to

have an ominous shape. And then a figure jumped out of the small ship that accompanied the larger ones. which landed next to her. The impact made the ground shake and Despara even lost her balance. She recognized that menacing-looking armor, and the sword, especially the sword.

„Whoever you are, in the name of the Order of Eclipse surrender!„ shouted Asindesa di Vir holding the ancient sword with both hands, and the feline woman turned her head to the side, clearly surprised.

„But it's true. You were given this sword. Well, I guess I'll take it.„ Despara said in her hoarse voice, and then started attacking again. This time, however, she had two Warriors against her, both armed with ancient weapons, and both highly trained. For a moment, they managed to stop her momentum and even began to gain the upper hand. But then, when Despara's blow bounced off the shoulder pad of the armor her father-in-law had given her, the woman's lips twisted into a strange smile and she uttered two words in a language unknown to her, and then the armor fell off her. "You didn't think my father would give you a gift that he couldn't take away, if only he wanted to? „ she said and dealt a quick blow, which she easily dodged. The lack of armor didn't really bother her, because she had been learning to fight without armor for most of her life anyway. The woman with the metal eyes began to back away, and for a moment she had the impression that she was leading them somewhere, and then suddenly she saw the glow of a thousand suns… and darkness fell.

He wasn't brave, he actually regretted what Lonnie had asked him to do... He knew his girlfriend was right and he shouldn't have pushed himself to the Front. He really just hoped that he would have the opportunity to become That Guy and in some way help others win. Only now it turned out that this woman so similar to Catra had arrived and started killing his friends. She was amazing, invincible, they couldn't fight her, so as soon as he obeyed

Lonnie's order, and he retreated, but after a moment he exchanged glances with Rogelio. They were hiding behind a large boulder, wide enough that no one could see them on the other side.

We can't leave her like this, can we?„ he asked his boyfriend, and he nodded and cleared his throat in agreement. However, when they looked behind the rocks, they saw that their girl was kneeling, and that woman was preparing to ask for time, but then Adora appeared, and drew the attention of the attacker, so they managed to approach the unconscious Lonnie and pull her aside, hiding behind the rock they had previously hidden on.

"Lonnie! Can you hear us?" he called, and felt an indescribable sense of relief when he heard her moan, and then she asked.

"Did we win?" Her voice was weak. She still tried to stand up, but he stopped her.

„This is a debatable issue„ He said diplomatically, and she once again lost consciousness again, and then he heard a ship and heard someone jump out of it, so when he looked around the rock he saw that there was a woman in ghoulish looking armor, who, to his surprise and relief, had sided with She-Ra. It looked like both women were gaining the upper hand, but since the exchange of fire had resumed, he decided to wait for the outcome of the fight, and he leaned over his girlfriend, grabbed her tightly and asked his boyfriend to help him pull her. But as soon as they started to pull Lonnie, he heard a deafening boom and saw that the entire area was bathed in a terrifyingly bright light, as if the sun he had heard so much about had risen over Etheria. He felt a wave of heat brought by the wind that had risen, and then everything started to get going. He turned around and saw Adora-She-Ra looking around in fear, as if she didn't know where she was, and the armored figure covered the visor with his hand. In the distance, on a huge glacier, he saw the fading light, and the ice glacier began to break apart, releasing a giant ship that had already gotten out and was clearly about to fly away.

„A true winner will not hesitate to use deception if he really cares about what he is fighting for.„ said the feline fencer, and attacked the women in armor with hooked blades. She made a few quick cuts, and suddenly chopped off her hand in which she was holding a strange sword. Now he saw that there were the same inscriptions on it as on his weapon... And the inscriptions said End of Eternity... Blade of Vengeance... Then he remembered his own weapon and drew it from the sheath, but hesitated. He did not know now whether he should transform at this moment, Perhaps no one would see him, enemies and Rogelio. Well, what did he want the lizard to know the truth? It was difficult, and he hesitated. At this time, the woman with metal eyes turned to She”Ra, who looked around as if she did not see Where her opponent was.

"I'm sorry I didn't block your sun!" she said and then Adora attacked her, the cat woman jumped to the side thus avoiding the blow.

„Darkness has come to you, hasn't it?„ Adora's opponent said, and she dodged another blow. He saw the desperation and terror on his former friend's face. Now he understood that she had lost her sight, and he himself felt an inexpressible sorrow.

„You can see the light again though... You just have to reach deeper into the power.„ she said and moved away almost mockingly dodging the next attacks. He grabbed harder almost ready to say the words... But then another figure fell from above, it was Itel, who hit the cat woman's back with great speed, wounding her. The blow, however, did not seem to seriously harm the person, but she turned to her and quickly grabbed her by the throat and squeezed.

„Do not interfere in the disputes between the student and his mentor!„ she said, lifting Itel up, and then he spoke the words.

„I have the Power!„ And then a light surrounded him, and he felt power and courage again. He grabbed his weapon with both

hands and attacked the cat woman, who turned at the last moment and blocked his strike with her metal arm.

„I didn't expect you. „ she said with sincere surprise and let go of the green”haired girl, and then began to fight him. At first with him as if they were equals, But then he saw that her attacks were getting weaker and slower and it was getting worse, and after a while Adora joined the fight again, who at least partially regained her sight. Together they attacked her and settled, pushing her further and further back.

„Well, you surprised me... Beware of triumph, for it is a trap of fate!„ And she struck her blades against each other and then they were all thrown back by a wave of energy. “There is one fire that burned the pyres.” she continued jumping away, she transformed the blades back into hands, and grabbed the sword abandoned by the person in armor, and said. “A two edges has sword held by every soldier...” she said, and he tried to attack her, but she made a wonderful piroue and jumped to the abandoned armor and finally said.

„ You can't change your fate... I feel so sorry for you. „ and the gate around her fell away into the void, which swallowed her and her armor... The fight was over, so then he swallowed a moment, turned, grabbed Lonnie and started to run.

The fight lasted another half hour, but when it turned out that the Hellknights had joined the Rebels, Lady Ka's Dogs retreated somewhere far away. Their new allies could not pursue them, because they were still allies of her father. They won the battle, but the cost was high. Dozens of rebel members died, most of them killed by her sister... Up until now, she had trouble accepting the fact that the other woman was her relative, but she already had a warcriminal in her family. Adora told her what had happened during the fight and what she had said to her. She wasn't sure what the other one was talking about, but it seemed that she wanted something from her wife, although none of them

were sure what. She certainly knew more than any of them. Her arrival was connected to the First Ones, although it didn't seem like she was on their side. In addition, she became her father's right hand, which did not bode well for all of them. After the shock, all of her muscles still hurt, but she still felt like she came out of the fight the best. Both Netossa and Seahawk had broken arms, many soldiers lost limbs in the fight with Despara, including Asindesa di Vir, although the Lady of Blades did not let this loss bother her, claiming that she would replace it with an artificial prosthesis anyway. Many members of the rebellion also lost their eyesight due to the explosion of the rock incinerator. From what she understood, this was also not such a big problem in the galaxy, because it could be replaced with cybernetic implants... Although it would be difficult to obtain them on this planet... The situation was much worse with the girl Saihe, who came to her wife's aid. During the explosion, she was unshielded and the closest of all of them to the explosion. She received a huge dose of radiation, and for several hours it was known whether she would survive. There had to be a double blood draw, and from what she knew she would have to take pills for the rest of her life. Several other Rebels had also been irradiated, including Lonnie, but surprisingly Kyle had escaped that fate, she could guess why.

But she felt sorry for Eti the most… Her sister had lost an eye, but she refused to receive the appropriate implant, and no one seemed to want to argue with her. However, it wasn't the fact that she had been mutilated that caused her sister the greatest suffering. Lady Ka had used some terrible device and taken control of her sister's Girlfriend. She had heard from Frosta and the rest that the white”haired girl had fought on the side of that vile woman… And then she had been taken by Lady Sorrowflame, no one knew where. She couldn't describe in words how vile it was. To take someone away from someone you loved… She knew how it felt, just like Adora…

Her wife was waiting for her near the landing site, sitting on one of the crates, leaning on her sword. She went to her, hugged her tightly, and then they kissed. When they broke apart, she said.

„We're going to Xadia...„ She said and immediately felt the silence resonate. Then her beloved embraced her and said.

„I see…”

It was only one word, but it said so much… She took a deep breath and began to explain.

„That ship is going there... It will fly for a very long time because it has no drive, as they call it Drift drive... But when it gets there... It wants to destroy that place... We can't let that happen... And besides, Shadow Weaver went there. They are looking for some old artifact that would allow them to open a passage to Eternia... I think they gathered Rosie there, but I'm not sure... Nightgale and Calamity probably went there... We are going there with the rebels... I am going too, and so is Queen Angela... We have some ships from Uncle Eti...

„ I see… „ her beloved said softly, and then hugged her.

„I'm sorry I have to go there and leave you here, but understand that I have to be with her, and She”Ra is needed here... We don't know what my father wishes to do.”

„ I understand everything. We also have some things to do here. Entrapta wants to stay here, and learn something about my origin and my power. We are planning a Journey to the center of the planet... We will get a certain device from the Shadows that will allow us to talk, although only for a minute a day, but it's something, right? „ She took her head in her hands and kissed it again. „ I will wait for you. „ said her wife, when she finished the kiss, they hugged once more and went to the deck of the Deadly Sword of Burning Fury.

She looked in the general direction her Beloved had been walking long after she had gone beyond her now very limited field of vision. Still, she had to wait for Netossa, who discreetly took her by the arm, and then led her towards the ship… Even though it was day, she felt as if dusk was falling… as if the light was dying

around her… was that really the case? She wished with all her might that it wasn’t so, but something deep in her heart told her that mortals were not impressed, for their fate had long been sealed by beings older and more powerful than time itself.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry I took so long to get this chapter out. It wasn't until after I wrote it that I realized I forgot about Melog.

Epilogue - Reaching through the Void

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When she got there, for the first few quarters of an hour she just lay on the grass and breathed heavily. She had to admit that lying there turned out to be very pleasant... The air here was as sweet as on her native Etheria... Magic also greeted her, She was also greeted by magic, perhaps not as powerful as on her homeworld, but still palpable. Sun shone, she still couldn't get used to the fact that it existed, and its rays gently caressed her skin. She saw some animals, birds or insects flying among the treetops. She didn't recognize many of them, but that was understandable, after all, she was in an alien world. Despite everything, compared to some places she had heard about, and even some regions of Etheria this place seemed surprisingly ordinary and friendly. She already knew a bit about the First Ones having colonized this world, and probably begun the terraforming process here… However, they had not acted radically enough to significantly change the planet's environment. She was reminded of the cursed swamps of Kranor Rill, whose biological mechanism was so advanced and invasive that thousands of years after their creators had been annihilated, it continued its work… However, perhaps its current growth had been stimulated by other ancient forces…

She couldn't just lie here all day, not to mention the mission that awaited her, she also had to reach some center of civilization, because she had no idea how to survive in the wilderness. She might be able to kill most of the monsters that might be hiding here, but Hunger and cold would kill her just like anyone else. She had some supplies, of course, she even took two storage bags, which could hold much more than there was and were surprisingly light, but even such simple things as pitching a tent and finding water were problematic for her. Now she realized what an

incredible feat it was that Mikach had survived on Beast Island, a place that even instilled fear in her, and he had been alone and had no chance of getting out. She had no right to complain... You wondered what gave him the strength to live there day after day... It was probably all the love for his daughter and wife, and the hope that he would meet them someday... She also hoped that she would meet her daughter someday... But above all, she had to save her... She knew, however, that it wouldn't be easy.

Finally, she sat down and cast a spell finding. It didn't show the exact location of the person she was looking for, but it still indicated that they were nearby... It was a very lucky twist of fate, although it immediately aroused her suspicions. Life had taught her not to believe in happy accidents and coincidences. The explanation was quite logical, however. The exit from the shadow path had to be near some significant point on this planet, and she guessed that Aaravos's student should be staying near such a place... The area looked inconspicuous, like the ruins of some insignificant temple, or maybe just a small sanctuary. There were many symbols depicting a mask, one side white, the other black, as well as symbols of her goddess. However, the locals probably knew nothing about Nethys and the spider. It was a small forest, from what she knew about the seasons, which after all did not occur on her planet, it was spring. Not bad, she was not sure if she had brought clothes warm enough for the cold winter. Her stay here seemed quite pleasant for now, which was almost worrying. She drank some isotonic drink from the bottle and then performed the second ritual, which summoned the shadow.

“Watch over me and look for the young woman” She commanded a being made of pure darkness. It wasn't a true shadow, an undead remnant of a soul, more like an elemental or an aberration, but it was useful. Then she put the heavy package on her back and started walking in the indicated direction. She knew that if you didn't find the girl for a long time, she would have to light a fire and cast a more powerful locator spell, but that could wait. It was worth looking around the area anyway. Maybe there was an inn somewhere here? Unfortunately, to her disappointment, there was no one nearby. She didn't see many

signs of civilization here, the only path cleared just enough to be traveled. In the distance, she saw a stone spire shooting up to the sky, it certainly wasn't a completely natural construction, although from this distance she was able to tell if it had been built by the First Ones or another advanced civilization. The shadow she had released was patrolling the area and suddenly informed her that it had noticed something. He wasn't very intelligent, he could only send her a message whether he had found the person she was looking for or had encountered danger. It wasn't entirely certain, it seemed that his knowledge came from her, and he was more likely to recognize obvious danger. It was worse with the less clear-cut one, but in this case she had to rely on luck. This signal, however, meant that it was the person she was looking for. Well, she had to admit that she hadn't expected to find her so quickly. At first she considered putting on a cloak of darkness and sneaking up, but then she changed her mind, it would probably be better not to start the acquaintance she was to cooperate with in the coming months with sneaky sneaking.

She approached the Glade located in front of a not very deep cave, around which a small shelter had been built. There were a few benches and a small hut, as well as a stone table. Some of these items had been left here long ago to make life easier for travelers, while others were more of a makeshift construction, made of leather and tangled branches. Still, they seemed quite sturdy, and perhaps they would survive here long after those who had made them had passed away. Two people stood by the fire. One was a young man who looked like a man. He had green hair and brown skin. At first glance, she took him for an elf, or Saihe, as they were called on her planet, but then she saw a few unusual features. He had horns on his head, and his hands had four fingers. He was dressed in a shirt and pants, but she could still see some strange tattoos or scars. He seemed a bit worried.

"I don't think we should stay near Stormspire too long. Eventually one of the dragons will notice us here," he said to the girl standing next to him. She was young, about the age her

stepdaughters had been when all this had started. She had fair skin and long hair, mostly black, but with a long white stripe. She was dressed in black robes, with gold trim, now well worn, and in her hand she had a golden staff with a black ball, looking like a black hole, hanging between its arms at the end.

„We have to stay here a little longer! He said that we have to wait here for someone. Someone who will help us!" she said in an excited voice, looking around, as if the person she was looking for was now going to come out of the trees. She was not wrong. She took a few steps and went out into the clearing. They both immediately jumped to their feet, and when they saw what she looked like, their eyes widened with fear. There was nothing strange about it, most sensible beings would draw their weapons if they saw someone like her coming out of the forest. Then the woman grabbed her staff, and the strange Elf stood with his legs spread wide, assuming a fighting stance.

„Don't come any closer! Just one more step and... you'll see!„ girl threatened her but she just smiled and said.

„I'm not going to do anything to you. I came here to... help you.„ she said carefully, and the young woman hesitated...

„You are the one Aaravos spoke of !... But I expected someone... different...„ Said the girl looking at her closely and flinched. She smiled at her and said.

„At your age, I also thought I would become someone else...„ She said and looked at the girl carefully, and then she felt IT in her! It was power, great and wonderful, very similar to what she felt from Adora when she saw her for the first time. The blood of the First Ones flowed in the veins of this girl, maybe not as pure as in the case of her adopted daughter, but already mature, just ready for Someone to guide her in the right way. She could do it, she was a great teacher. This girl was the perfect Student. She saw in her great enthusiasm and desire to gain knowledge without considering the opinions of others... And the cost. She was determined, ready to sacrifice, and also very... naive. Yes, this girl

would finally be the student she had always dreamed of. She could spend some time with her and make her a devoted right hand... But that was not why she came here. She was to act in accordance with the will of the Crawling Chaos. She was to free this cursed sorcerer, to save her daughter, the only one who loved her.

„What happened to you that you look like that.„ asked the boy with green hair, and she smiled at him, making him flinch, and said.

„I made bad life choices, for which others had to suffer. „ She said and when she saw that they were looking at her worriedly she decided to change the subject and asked. „Can I sit down… Do you have tea?„ she said and then the girl pointed to her paw and said. „ Of course, now we will brew! „ the girl said and She started looking for something in the packages and when she took out the bag of herbs she asked. „ Does this mean that you are... A friend of Aravos ...?

She barely held back from bursting into dark laughter. This girl was real.

"Aravos and I have a long-standing relationship.„ she said very euphemistically. She knew she couldn't trust the ancient sorcerer, but she also needed his help. So she decided not to interfere in his relationship with this girl for now, even if in this way she could allow her to meet a fate similar to the one she had experienced, or even worse.

The girl nodded and said.

„My father... He was the first person in a hundred years who contacted with him, but...„ her voice broke, and the green-haired Elf put his hand on her shoulder. She had already guessed that there was more to these two than just friendship or common goals.

„I heard that something terrible happened to him... I feel sorry for you...„ she said and there was silence, during which the girl was immersed in sad and gloomy memories.

"So you came to help me bring him back to life, right?" She looked at her with hope in her eyes, and she nodded slowly.

„I'm very happy, because this will be an unimaginably difficult task. And by the way, my name is Claudia...„ Girl smiled suddenly, brightening up, and then her companion added.

„And I'm Terry.„ she had the impression that he wanted to shake her hand, but then he saw the clawed hands and changed his mind. She didn't blame him...

„My name is…„ she hesitated, because she could use any name here, either one of those she had used in her life or one she had just come up with. She could finally break away from the past and start a new life under a new name. But today she wasn't going to run away from her sins.

„My name is Shadow Weaver… „ she looked at the couple, in whose eyes she saw surprise, confusion and anxiety.

„Well, that's the name...„ Terry said carefully, trying to smile, but he was clearly afraid of her.

„Indeed, that is a name...„ she said, smiling sadly.

Calamity kicked the stone with all her might and was surprised to see that she had broken her finger. She felt no pain, only slight discomfort, and she knew that in a moment her body would return to its previous state, but her ego was wounded. This was an accident that mortals could tell in anecdotes and jokes, not something that happened to half-goddesses! She groaned in anger and looked at Nightgale, who was observing her humiliation with surprisingly stoic calm. The young sorceress probably couldn't understand how difficult it all was for someone who was

used to being able to tear apart any being she encountered. And now she couldn't... She couldn't even piss herself without help, unless she pissed her panties, which would be equally degrading to her dignity. When that... being cut off her hands, she was just about to go to the side. It was absurd that despite being a practically perfect and invincible being, she still had to worry about such simple and disgusting activities as urinating and feces… Or shitting and pissing… She tried to hold out for a few hours, hoping that her hands would grow back, but in the end she couldn't take it anymore and called Nightgale. She would rather ask Shadow Weaver's daughter for help than let her servants watch her humiliation. It had to be admitted that the young sorcerer behaved surprisingly decently in the current… situation. She didn't say anything, and Ani didn't smile mockingly, and when it was over, she didn't bring up the subject, for which she was so grateful, of course within reason. She was still just a mortal. They managed to dismantle parts of the mechanisms from the inside of the dome and connect them with what they had brought with them, although it was probably all thanks to her companions, because with the hands of a baby that had grown in her after a few hours, there wasn't much she could do anyway. In truth, she intended to manipulate the queen into connecting the artifact to one of the runestone sockets that were empty and rebuild the matrix on this planet, but she burned her bridges behind her. Perhaps she should have been more sensible. She shouldn't have succumbed to temptation, after all, if she followed the orders of the Crawling Chaos, she would be able to get the justice she deserved.

Then they went to the outskirts of the ruins left by the Krellans, where the teleportation device was hidden. It was a small round building, resembling a dome, which was covered with layers of mud and strange local plants to disguise it. They got inside after Nightgale and the young cultist dug furiously for several hours. It was easier for them thanks to the help of these small creatures, many of whom followed the dark sorcerer, treating her like a minor deity. Eventually, they managed to dig up the place and their eyes saw the interior. Everything was covered in the same

veined stone that conducted geomagical energy so well. The device that operated this Teleporter was not impressive, but it seemed to function. She had learned enough about the technology of this ancient race to try to make it work. Of course, she had to rely on the young sorcerer for this too, so she followed her instructions with great care. She actually had the impression that she liked her a little, like one likes a tasty dish... It was a perfect comparison!

„Now we just have to wait for that girl to come back with the Coordinates.„ she said scratching her regrowing arms, then added. „ here is one problem though. This device has enough energy to transport us only once, but until we activate the Bloodstone on the other side, we won't be able to return, or get any support. „ She explained thanking the ancients for all those hours spent in the swamp learning how to operate the technology of an extinct race.

„You'll definitely manage, you're very capable after all... Besides, you're a nearly impossible-to-kill monster capable of tearing a man in half with your bare hands, I really believe in you!„ Her companion replied with a hint of sarcasm in her voice . She also understood that the most important thing hadn't been said out loud. If they failed to activate the bloodstone, Nightgale would die, and a very painful death at that. Of course, if what the Creeping Chaos said was true, then there was a high probability that they would be annihilated along with all the enemies of that lousy civilization. Sometimes it happened that even demigods had to accept their helplessness.

Thus the hours passed, during which she vented her frustration on stones and frogs. Her companions took refuge under the dome, but she was bored enough to wander, and finally Nightgale came out and began to watch her with a mixture of boredom and Anxiety, after all, at any moment the queen might want to reclaim her runestone, and if she succeeded, the fate of the young sorcerer was not bright. However, when Twilight had already fallen and only a few darker and more sinister moons illuminated the area, they saw the approaching shadows of drops

„I have the impression that all of Mrs. Ka's subordinates, as well as Lady Sorrowflame, have come to us.„ She said with genuine surprise, and then she felt a surge of power and heard a hoarse voice behind her.

„In fact, things have gotten a little more complicated, but that's even better for you.„ said Despara.

Lady K never before traveled in the mouth of a vampire dragon, and She had the impression that No one who had found themselves in Lady Sorrowflame's jaws had ever managed to survive, so she could say that she was very lucky. She had to admit that it was not a very pleasant experience, and she did not intend to repeat it again. After a while, they reached the ships, and then the dragoness spat them out quite brutally onto the hard, frozen ground, and threw her subordinates out of her claws. Nothing even happened to them, although from what she noticed, Most of them shit themselves with fear. She felt the explosion of the rock incinerator, but it seemed to her that they were also far away, and besides, the ancient dragoness had an energy shield, so she doubted that they would receive a large dose of radiation, but just in case, she would take the appropriate medication. Right after they arrived, a more terrifying cat girl appeared. She was naked, which in her case wasn't the most pleasant sight, in fact she had never seen someone with so many different kinds of scars on their body. She wondered how on earth she had survived all of this, if it was the work of one of the gods or someone like that, she was very grateful to him, because he had just saved her from the wrath of the Lord Admiral.

The cat woman had another sword with her, the same one that belonged to Asindesa di Vir. That was also very interesting.

„I see you found yourself a new toy... Does this mean the Lady of Blades is dead...„ She asked with curiosity in her voice. Teasing the Hellknight was very amusing, but if she decided to join Antares' enemies, then she would be better off dead.

„She is alive, as is my sister... I hope that applies to the other one as well?„ The Lord Admiral's new right hand asked, piercing her through and through with the gaze of those metal eyes.

„Just like you ordered, not a single hair fell from her head, although her friend could have ruffled her a bit. „ she glanced at the deaf girl who stood next to her, staring blankly ahead. She actually felt uncomfortable being near her. She saw how dangerous warrior she was, despite her nature as a kind-hearted idiot, stupid even for this place, and she guessed that as soon as she broke free from the leash, whoever was responsible for her imprisonment…

„She-Ra is also alive, but that was the plan. Now I am taking you to Lady Cala.„ The cat girl said in a commanding tone. She truly was her Father's daughter.

„That's a good idea Despara. She and her mentor... They are involved in some enterprise related to the First Ones... „ The dragoness explained in a booming voice.

„ So you did what our allies asked us to do? „ Mrs. Ka asked with curiosity.

„Indeed... They were right that seeing is believing, but also that the truth can break. „ Lady Sorrowflame said and shuddered at her words. If something could break a dragon older than most of beings in the galaxy, then she had to know some terrible truth... Well, no one is as strong as they seem.

Nightgale watched the arrival of the ships with some surprise. At the beginning of this journey, she had not expected the great forces that would be involved in their expedition. Aaravos stood beside her, admiring the arrival of the ships, rubbing his beard with his hand.

„Don't you feel the excitement just before the beginning of a great adventure! Here is a team of righteous heroes setting off on an

epic journey to oppose Evil with the power of their noble hearts and bring hope to the entire Universe?„ He said and Whirled around her. She gave him a skeptical look.

„ The only thing that is true is that we are going on an journey and maybe it will be epic, but the rest... „ She replied looking at him skeptically, and he laughed and said.

„Truth is a negotiable construct…”

She didn't feel like discussing philosophical topics with him, especially such absurd ones. One or two ships were able to land even in such a place, but most had to hang in the air. Lady Sorrowflame landed next to them in Dragon form. It was already evening, and she guessed that the spells allowed her to travel during the day, although she suspected that she had accelerated on the deck of one of these ships and jumped out of it. Only when they were almost at their destination. Behind the ships landed Despara appeared with her friend with metallic skin.

"Indeed, things have become a bit more complicated, but for you it is even better." Despara said. The cat-like girl had a completely different sword in her hands, the sight of which caused concern in Lady Cala''s eyes. It was the blade of Asindesa di Vir, and that could mean that...

„I understand that our noble knight's problem has been solved... Shadow Weaver will be inconsolable... „ said the Dread Aristocrat, and then Despara looked at her, and slapped her. The tips of her fingers transformed into claws during the blow.

„So it's true that they both were very close. I had to hit youto teach you not to take pleasure in the misfortune of dream books. „ she said in that hoarse voice looking at the beautiful monstrosity, whose flaws had almost healed. Lady Cala looked at her coldly, but then unexpectedly the feline woman threw a blade at her feet.

„Take them. You might find them useful, as well as the armor that belonged to the Lord Admiral... And something else."

She moved away and a white-haired girl appeared before their eyes…

„Rosie?„ She asked in surprise, and then she saw that the girl's eyes were clouded, she was standing strangely stiff, and then she saw what had bitten into her neck. She felt an indescribable pang of conscience. This girl was good, she had never been mean or cruel to anyone, she was full of naive kindness. They didn't know each other very well, but she saw that she was better than anyone present, like night was better than day. What a horrible thing they had done. Lady Cala, seeing the girl, smiled nastily. Sole to her and gently touched her cheek with her fingers.

„It's a wonderful gift, I really thank you. she said, but Nightgale saw sadness and pain in the eyes of this girl with metallic skin. She put hand on Despara's shoulder .... For a moment I have the impression that both girls are talking without words, and then a strange grimace appeared on Despara's face and she approached Calamity . . .

„Remember that she is not your property. I am not proud of what I did, although it was necessary. So try to make sure that she does not get more harm than necessary because of you, because when her mission is over, she will be freed, so think about who she will take revenge on... „ she approached, staring at the aristocrat with those dead metal eyes, but she only smiled and climatically, so the woman added, ready. „ And do not think that some terrible accident will happen to her. Because then I will get the second device and this time I will attach it to you, do you understand?" when she said this, honest horror appeared on Lady Cala's face. Then the cat woman turned and looked at Lady Ka, who simply threw a mind control bracelet at them.

„Being around her was creepy enough as it was."

She wanted to say something, to somehow comfort the girl, but how could she do that when she was co-responsible for her suffering? She was already opening her mouth to say a few words, but then came an unimaginable pain, and she fell to her knees.

Captain Blazebringer detected the massive ship leaving Etheria's orbit. Sure, compared to the void galleon it was a mere insect, but it still piqued his interest. He immediately traced its trajectory and felt confused. He wondered for a moment where it had gone, then began searching through his memory records and understood the purpose of that warship.

„We are beginning a hard acceleration. Destination Xadia.„ He announced to his crew... They were not many, and truth be told, he did not even need them. But they made things easier... And thanks to them, being slowly absorbed by this ship was almost bearable. Almost… But he accepted his suffering, for it was the price of the path he was following. He was one of the last knights of eternity, perhaps the last, and it was on his shoulders that they would save the universe... Even if he had to cause the deaths of millions.

But he had a better idea… Albeit a very risky one.

Herold slept dreaming of an eternal, insatiable Hunger. All of her components were hungry… But it was a permanent state. She knew that it would never be satiated, unless… It was a part of the thoughts that were inaccessible to her. However, she knew that everything was for the purpose of satisfying an insatiable desire. Recently, however, she too began to feel new desires. Certain memories returned. They spun in her mind and in those not fully developed minds of her components. It was a strange feeling, almost painful. However, she could not get it out of her consciousness. She had to do something about it.

She left a few small spy components in orbit where she was supposed to arrive, which were to observe what was happening there. They couldn't see much, but they would at least allow her to control interplanetary traffic. She had just sensed something leaving orbit, first a giant warship, and then a large group of ships. She reached there with her mind and sensed them. And only one of them, but the other one too! The other one, the ones she had given her name. Yes, she had once had a name! She had been... someone. True, for a very short time, but she had been. She felt an overwhelming desire to go after them... But that was against the will of the Swarm... Or maybe... Maybe she could convince the Swarm to let her go after that ship? She contacted the semi-divine consciousness and waited for a response... To her surprise, she received permission. At first she wondered why, then she was shown Where the ship was going and she learned why this place was so important… She agreed and Split off from the main part of the swarm and flew in that direction to a place called Xadia …

Chapter End Notes

This is the end of the Princess of Nothingness, but don't worry, our heroes will return in Princess of Stars.

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